The Cryopod to Hell (Refresh)

by Klokinator

Volume 3 of 3 — Parts 610+

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Part 610: "REWIND!"

January 13th, 2021. Portland, Oregon, USA.

It was a cold winter day, a day without snow, but one where the wind wove its way into the gaps between clothing and skin to chill the person beneath. A cold day, but otherwise seemingly ordinary.

Jason Hiro sat in bed, looking out the window at the world outside. This city, a rather large one with a population over 500,000 people, was positioned at the northern edge of Oregon state. A large river divided it from its northern Washington neighbor city, Vancouver.

But Jason's apartment had no particularly decent views. He could only see the five-story apartment complex across the street, and the one beside it, and the other ones beside that one as well.

He could peer through his window to the street two stories below... if he so wished. There, he could look down at the people walking to and fro, going about their day. He could also look up at the overcast sky, the sun hidden behind his apartment, well out of sight. Perhaps he might even spot some pigeons flying about, if he so wished.

But he didn't do that. Instead, he dazedly stared out the window, looking more than a little confused.

"What's... going on?" Jason asked aloud, of no-one in particular. "Something seems off today."

He couldn't quite put his finger on what was bothering him. It was an odd feeling. It felt as if there was something important he needed to be doing, but he couldn't place what it was.

Several minutes passed. The apartment next door, with its ever-annoying occupant, some old man Jason had never spoken to but had seen going in and out of his house every so often, blared the TV at maximum volume. The old man clearly had hearing issues, but Jason always felt a little too intimidated by his grizzled beard to confront him about it.

"...stocks down 13% in light of President Brian Chutley's recent declaration regarding the potential of a pandemic coming from China. President Chutley stated to reporters that

he would go to every possible length to strengthen the CDC's provisions in preparation for the outbreak of what is being designated 'Covid-19.' And here, we have President Chutley's remarks as he addressed the nation on Tuesday..."

Jason listened to the TV idly while his mind moved with the speed of a slug to try and figure out just what the heck he was supposed to be doing today.

"Hmm... something... it was something important..."

Jason's eyes idly wandered to a photo of a man, woman, and five children on his bedside desk. He reached over and picked it up to look at it. For some reason, the photo made him feel sadder than usual today. It felt like he had lost them all over again.

"Mom... dad..." Jason muttered, looking at the picture of his former foster family, Amanda and Robert Tate.

Usually, when he looked at this picture, he would feel an immense amount of anguish, a deep pang of empathy and loss that made the rest of his day a little bleaker.

But today, that feeling was different. The sadness he felt was more distant than usual, as if they had passed away hundreds of years ago, and the pain inflicted on his heart had long scabbed over, only to just now rip the wound open.

It felt like a distant sort of nostalgia, like a favorite sad movie from childhood. Jason couldn't pinpoint why it felt so alien, only that it did.

He gently ran his thumb over Amanda's face, then Robert, then the other kids Jason had grown up with.

Cody was doing decently, all things considered. He was 20 now, in college. Jason hadn't spoken to him in a few years, but he figured Cody had rebounded relatively well, despite his past trauma.

Emily wasn't as fortunate. She and Robert were extremely close, and his accidental death broke her psyche. She spent the last several years in and out of rehab for substance abuse.

Honestly, Jason thought it wouldn't be long before she... but that wasn't a thought he liked to imagine.

Then there was Jason himself, and the fallout from losing the two foster parents he cared about the most.

He was doing well.

Wasn't he?

...Wasn't he?

Jason frowned. He finally seemed to recall something, stood up from his bed, and flinched when his feet touched the cold vinyl floor. He fumbled around and found his slippers under the bed and stepped inside them, then walked over to turn on the central heat before turning to look at his calendar.

And there it was.

Today was the day. Somehow, he had completely forgotten.

How could such an important event slip his mind?

"Something must be off with me..." Jason mumbled, looking at the floor with a pained expression. "I'm being totally dense today."

This apartment, funded by the last dregs of money at his disposal, was no longer within his ability to pay. He lost his job a few months ago. Even with his savings, he hadn't been able to last the winter without finding a new job.

Then, a month and a half ago, at the end of November, he stumbled across an advertisement online, talking about a new cryogenics procedure asking for volunteers.

Sign up, get paid $100,000 to go into cryostasis for one year, with the understanding that the scientists might fail to revive you. The payout was large enough to make him set his inhibitions aside and carefully consider whether or not this was a good idea.

Ultimately, since Cryotek was a reputable company that had successfully frozen and unfrozen monkeys, Jason decided to accept the offer. He called them up that day and set an appointment.

An appointment that had finally arrived.

"Today is the day." Jason said, looking at his scrawny reflection in the mirror. "My second chance."

At most, Jason weighed 140 pounds (65.5 kilos) soaking wet. Standing at just 5'10 (177.8cm) tall, he was an average-sized teenager, barely considered an adult by the law, but not much of an adult in mind and body.

Or at least that's how he felt yesterday. But for some reason, he didn't feel the same way today.

"Am I really that desperate?" Jason said out loud again, still not talking to anyone in particular. "I'm going to freeze myself for $100,000? Can't I come up with a better way to make money?"

He wandered over to his bedside table where he had laid out the waiver Cryotek made him sign. He frowned when he read some of the terms.

"Participant agrees to arrive on the specified date and submit themselves to a medical screening. Participant agrees to cryogenically place themselves in suspended animation for a duration of one year, or three hundred and sixty five days, in exchange for the agreed-upon reimbursement. If the client wishes to cancel these terms, he must pay... oh for the love of- what kind of idiot am I, agreeing to these terms? **Seriously?!** I have to pay a 20% cancellation fee if I want to back out? That's ridiculous! They're clearly just trying to exploit a young man with no worldly knowledge!"

He paused. Then he blinked.

"Though, that's what I am. Right? A young man. No worldly knowledge. It's only normal I'd be suckered by the $100,000 payout. And I'm depressed anyway. I think I am. I was? Am I depressed?"

Jason frowned again.

He was feeling *exceptionally* strange today.

Everything told him that he possessed far more wisdom and knowledge than an 18 year old should have, along with insight obtainable only by living a long and fulfilling life. But when he tried to remember why he felt that way, he couldn't quite remember the reason.

"Strange. It's all so strange..." Jason muttered.

He walked over to the fridge and opened it, finding it to be exceptionally bare and poorly stocked. A couple cans of Coke and Pepsi were all that greeted his eyes, along with a mostly-empty jar of mayo, some wilted lettuce, and some ham and cheese well past their due dates.

"God. I live like such a slob. My wife would be pissed if she saw this." Jason muttered, as he shook his head and closed the fridge door. "Soda will just rot my teeth. I'm better off

just drinking some water- huh?"

Jason paused again, a look of confusion clouding his eyes.

"Wife... do I have a wife?"

He looked around his small, studio apartment.

There were no signs of female activity to be seen.

"No. I don't. Weird. Thought for a second I... well, whatever. Man. It's going to be one of those days, huh? I guess the Cryotek thing is really stressing me out."

He shrugged.

"No way to back out now. Might as well just honor the commitment and get on with it. Hopefully I'll wake up in a year and just put this whole mess behind me. I can make that $100k stretch, too. Maybe start up a business or something."

Jason spent the next thirty minutes prepping himself for the day. He brushed his teeth, took a shower, then rifled through his drawers for some clean clothes.

"No sense in cleaning the place out." Jason muttered, before walking around and grabbing a few personal items, such as the photo of his foster family, and his cheap Acer laptop. "Never did like Mister Jonas anyway. That old shithead can clean it up himself. As far as he'll know-, I'll simply have disappeared off the face of the Earth."

Jason chuckled, thinking vicious thoughts about his mean old curmudgeon of a landlord. But then he stopped laughing and frowned.

"...What did he look like again? Feels like I haven't seen him in hundreds of years."

No matter how Jason tried, he couldn't recall Mister Jonas's face. Only his name. That left him feeling perplexed again.

"Man what is going ON with me today?" Jason groaned. "Get it together, man!"

Jason grabbed his duffel bag and backpack, grunting as he slung the duffel-strap over his shoulder to help assist in carrying it more comfortably.

"Well... guess this is it. Bye, tiny, cramped little apartment. Won't miss you."

Jason stepped outside, slammed his door shut, then began walking down the street, his new life ahead of him.

"It's only about ten blocks to Cryotek. I'll just walk." Jason muttered. "Fuck it. I'll grab some food along the way."

His wallet didn't have a lot of money left. Only about a hundred dollars. Enough for a couple of cab rides, but not nearly enough to cover rent.

As Jason walked, the bustling city center of Portland seemed to hum in the distance. Located about a mile from that area, Jason could still hear the distant wails of police sirens, ambulances, or perhaps firetrucks as they went around, saving lives.

There weren't a lot of people walking the streets at nine in the morning. Jason passed by a couple of gangster-looking men, one white and one Latino. They side-eyed his duffel bag, perhaps thinking about grabbing it for themselves.

But when they met Jason's eyes, despite his small and unassuming stature, they seemed to notice something formidable about him. They simply averted their eyes and kept walking.

Jason continued to walk. He thought about those two men and how in the past, when he walked past a couple of scary people like that, he'd be the one to avert his eyes instead. But this time, he felt no fear at all. Their threat level was so low it didn't even register for him, whereas they seemed to instinctively understand that he was not as simple as he seemed.

When did I become so formidable? Jason wondered, metaphorically scratching his head. *I guess they just aren't that tough. Or maybe I'm overthinking it. Either way, they were only human. If they were Demons, that'd be a totally different story!*

But naturally, Jason corrected himself. *Not that demons exist. My brain is simply acting silly again.*

His ever increasing awareness of his 'weird' thoughts became duller as time passed. He stopped at a local taco stand and bought himself a grande burrito, then sat down on a bench nearby, silently munching it as cars passed by. Normally, he'd tuck his bag of belongings under the bench, behind his feet, as if to protect it, but this time, he didn't even bother.

Despite casually eating his food, Jason watched the people around him carefully, as if to assess any possible threats. With surprising ease, he managed to pick out the benign passers-by and the malevolent ones as well. Portland, naturally, was a city with a decent amount of crime, so Jason always knew to keep his eyes out. But he even surprised himself with his observational skills.

I guess I'm just good at this now, too. He thought.

Jason glanced off to the side, where he saw a Renaissance festival taking place at the local park. Lots of men and women streamed inside, dressed in clothes resembling peasant and noble garb from the 1800's and before.

"Bet my wife would love to go to one of those..." Jason muttered, before frowning. "And there I go saying more weird shit."

He finished his burrito, tossed the wrapper in the trash, then picked up his bags and continued walking. Before long, he made it the ten blocks to the Cryotek Warehouse, where their two-story outer glass facade concealed the vast underground complex where all the cryogenic pods would ultimately be stored. The building shone in the midday light, making Jason squint as the reflected sun tried its damnedest to blind him.

With a deep sigh of resignation, Jason slowly strode into Cryotek, his hesitation palpable. Everything about this situation felt wrong to him, but he couldn't pin why. It almost felt as if an entirely different version of himself signed up for this, and he woke up today completely blindsided by what he had to do.

But ultimately, it was him who made the decision, and he had to abide by it, his terrible memory be damned.

"$20,000 to cancel. Man. What was I thinking?" Jason grumbled. "Who signs up for something like this unless they have a death wish? Then again, didn't I? It's so hard to remember."

The glass front doors slid open automatically, gliding along silently as warm, comforting air wafted against his body. Despite wearing a thick coat, sweat building up under his clothes still made him feel rather chilly.

Jason looked around the entry area. It was extremely large, a huge open space with a food court to the right where several Cryotek employees sat, enjoying their lunch break, their identities made obvious by the blue and white Cryotek logo emblazoned on their shirts. It was a fairly simply one, a vector image in the shape of a capsule with several tubes poking off to the side, with the company name boldly emblazoned on top.

To the left, a row of benches signaled the waiting area, where five other people were already sitting, nervousness palpable on their faces. Jason guessed they must be the other cryogenic study participants. Most of them were young adults, but one surprisingly old

man also joined the group. He appeared the least bothered by what was soon to happen. Jason assumed that was because he had didn't have much time remaining in his life. This time-extension might give him a shot at reviving in anear-future where age reversal tech was ever so slightly more advanced.

But then again, the human struggle against mortality was simply one of their species' defining traits. It was a timeless tale; the struggle of man versus death. It was a tale man was always destined to lose. Humans died, and that was that.

Jason walked forward, making eye contact with a curly-haired brunette with bright red lips. She smiled at him, but his heart didn't stir in the slightest. He found this confusing, since he had always been a bit of a nerd when it came to women, and would even stumble over his words a little if someone attractive enough showed him any positive attention. Yet, now, her smile meant nothing to him.

My wife's smile would be prettier. Jason thought idly, reminiscing on some faceless idea of a 'wife' he clearly never had. Why he kept thinking about the idea of already having a wife, he could not understand.

"Jason Hiro." He said to the receptionist, noting her name-tag identified her as Leeta. He'd never heard the name before, but it sounded vaguely Greek. "I'm here for the uh... the cryogenic appointment."

"Hello, Jason! Thank you for making it in a little early!" Leeta chirped, smiling a little brighter at him. Despite his goofy appearance, he carried himself with a strange confidence, which she felt was noticeably more appealing than his thin frame and unimpressive bodily build implied. "I need you to sign some waivers before you start, consenting to all the procedures you'll be undergoing today. I will also need to register all the items you've brought along. Before we start, do your personal belongings contain any firearms, narcotics, or other paraphernalia?"

"No. Nothing like that." Jason said. "Pictures of family. Clothes. Some random knick-knacks."

"Alright, that's good to hear." Leeta responded, turning to type on her computer.

She fell silent, her fingers whizzing across the keys at a speed Jason found to be slightly awe-inspiring. How the heck was she so fast? She must have gone to college and aced her typing classes, or perhaps she just used computers a lot.

Perhaps if this was yesterday, Jason might express some visible interest on this subject and awkwardly chat her up, trying to fish for information, maybe try and make a positive impression.

But his heart just wasn't in it today. He felt like a completely different man, and in the end, what was typing speed as an accomplishment anyway? Fighting demons was a lot more impressive, and he only thought women who could do that were worth his time.

Huh... what a strange thing to think. Jason counter-thought, scrutinizing his mental tangents.

Leeta typed, and typed, and typed some more. Finally, she raised her eyes from her monitor to look at him.

"Have you ingested any food or drink within the last twelve hours?"

Jason blinked. "Uh... yes. Was I not supposed to?"

Leeta paused. She cocked her head slightly. "Our medical examiners should have gone over this with you last week. You aren't supposed to eat or drink anything before entering cryostasis. Did they fail to give you a call?"

"A call..." Jason said slowly, trying to recall if anything of the sort happened a week ago.

Unfortunately, try as he might, he just couldn't think back that far. For some reason, a week ago might as well have been a hundred years.

"I... don't know." Jason said awkwardly. "Sorry. I'm having some... memory issues today. Not sure why. Feels like something changed last night and I can't place what."

"I see." Leeta said, frowning slightly. She smushed her lips together in a thoughtful sort of way, then reached for the phone. "Hold on. Let me call Ms. Langley over. She can examine you to make sure you're fit for cryostasis. Sudden memory issues could indicate a problem we need to be aware of."

Jason chewed his lower lip. "Uh... if I'm found to not be fit for stasis, will they cut me out of the tests? I... can't afford the cancellation fee."

"We can always work out a repayment plan." Leeta said with a smile. "You have insurance, right?"

"Insurance." Jason repeated, losing himself momentarily in thought. "Insurance. I do. I might? I'm not sure. I don't remember."

"You don't remember that either?" Leeta asked, raising her eyebrow another millimeter. "Let's just have Ms. Langley inspect you before we take any drastic steps."

Jason nodded slowly, feeling a pit start to form in his stomach. He did not like the way this conversation was going. "S-sure. Alright."

At Leeta's request, he wandered over to the waiting area and sat down across from the old man, and beside a young blonde woman with long hair. She was even more drop-dead gorgeous than Leeta, but as before, her beauty didn't move him. Somehow, despite being eighteen, the same age as Jason, he found her to be way too young for his tastes.

I feel like I'm into older women now. Jason thought absentmindedly. *At least more mature ones. When did that happen?*

The old man looked at Jason, grunting gruffly at him.

"Having trouble?"

Jason nodded. "I think so. Memory issues. I also ate food before I came here. I hope they don't make me cancel. I can't afford the twenty thousand dollar fee..."

"Young kids like you shouldn't be here." The old man grumbled. "If they give you any trouble, I'll pay that fee for you. No worries. I'm loaded. Pulled some strings to get myself into this test."

Jason blinked. "You're rich, but you signed up for cryostasis? Why?"

"I have a rare neurological disease." The old man said. "My hope is that if I freeze myself, a certain new treatment the Chinese recently devised may have passed FDA approval by the time I get out. Otherwise... I probably won't meet a good end."

"Oh." Jason said, not quite sure how to respond. "That's heavy."

"Yeah. Problem is, President Chutley is rumored to be passing a six-month freeze on FDA approvals. It's got me spooked. Hope we vote that cunt out by next year."

"Yeah. Same." Jason responded, once again unsure of how to continue the conversation's flow. He didn't know much about politics, and he didn't have much of an impression of Chutley at all.

Jason glanced at the blonde girl sitting beside him. She looked up and met his gaze.

"So, why are you entering Cryostasis?" Jason asked.

"I'm not." The girl replied. "I came here to see someone off."

"Gotcha. I hope that works out for you." Jason replied.

The girl remained quiet for a moment, looking into Jason's eyes before looking away.

"How about you?" She asked. "Are you still planning to go along with this procedure?"

"Yeah." Jason answered, before pausing. "Well. Actually. I don't know. Maybe. I can't afford the cancellation fee. It's only for a year, anyway. The $100k will be a big boon for me. I just don't know what I was thinking when I chose to come here."

"You're having second thoughts?" She asked, looking at him more carefully.

This girl is kind of intense. Jason thought, wondering why she was asking such pointed questions.

"Something like that. But I'll go along with it if they okay things for me. By the way... do I know you?"

Jason squinted slightly. The more he looked at her, the more familiar she seemed.

A faint spark of light seemed to flicker in the girl's eyes. "I don't know. *Do you?*"

"My name's Jason." Jason said. "What's yours? Did we maybe go to the same school or something?"

"We didn't." The girl said. "We definitely didn't. But my name is Daisy..."

"Oh, Daisy?" Jason repeated, frowning slightly.

After a few moments, he smiled. "That's a pretty name."

Daisy's smile seemed to deflate, ever so slightly. "Thanks."

Once again, Jason felt slightly confused. Daisy's reactions weren't quite what he thought they'd be. She almost seemed to be expecting something from him, but he couldn't place what it was.

After a few moments, Daisy rose to her feet. She smiled at him, then sighed. "No matter what choice you make, I'm rooting for you."

"Oh. Well, thank you." Jason said, mystified by her strange words. "I'm, uh, rooting for you too."

Daisy stared at him again, then she turned and walked away. She briskly exited Cryotek, leaving Jason to his thoughts.

Jason glanced around the waiting area. There were a couple other people seated not far away, but two weird conversations in a row made him apprehensive about chatting anyone else up.

Luckily, at that moment, a door behind the reception desk swished open, and a brown-haired woman with permed curls and big thick-rimmed glasses strode out, turning to the waiting area to scan the group of four before looking directly at him.

"Jason Hiro?" She asked.

He stood up, hefted his duffel bag and backpack, then quickly strode over to the woman. "That's me."

She extended her hand. "I'm Rebecca Langley, one of the assistant medical examiners here at Cryotek. Would you mind coming with me to the back to answer some questions?"

Jason quickly reached out and shook her hand, taking care to match her strength. It was never okay in his book to crush another person's hand when they offered, and personally he hated when big macho-types pulled that crap to assert dominance or whatever.

"Hello, is it okay if I call you Rebecca, or do you prefer Ms. Langley?"

"Rebecca is fine." She said, smiling back at him. "Just follow me to my office and we'll make this quick, alright?"

Jason nodded. He and Rebecca headed into the back, down a spacious corridor, past multiple office doors, until they arrived at one with Rebecca's name on the glass. She lead him inside, then pulled the blinds shut and closed the door.

"No cubicles, huh?" Jason said, to make conversation. "That must be nice."

He took a seat at the desk, and Rebecca sat opposite him, turning to look at her flatscreen display with a smile.

"Oh, it is. Cryotek has treated me excellently compared to my last job. The pay isn't too bad either, plus I get benefits."

"Benefits." Jason repeated. "That's nice these days, what with rumors of that super-flu in the news."

"I'm sure Cryotek will take good care of me." Rebecca replied, keeping her tone diplomatic and professional. "Now, what's this about the memory issues you've been experiencing? Can you give me more details?"

"Of course." Jason said. "So, it started this morning when I woke up. I just wasn't feeling like myself, and I've been having all kinds of weird thoughts..."

Keeping the strangest thoughts to himself, particularly those weird ones about demons and liking 'mature' women, Jason explained to Rebecca over the next few minutes the odd gaps in his memory and his internal musings that didn't seem to sync up with what he should have been like yesterday, or the day before.

Rebecca, to her credit, listened silently and without judgment, only pausing to ask follow-up questions.

Eventually, she nodded and typed some words on her computer.

"I'll need to run a MRI to be sure, but it doesn't sound like anything serious."

"It doesn't?" Jason asked, feeling slightly baffled.

"I'm actually a PhD neurologist, you see." Rebecca explained. "What you're describing is most likely stress-induced memory loss. I won't lie, you're not the first person to go through something like this prior to entering a clinical trial as... scary... as the first human-tested cryostasis treatment. I'm sure you've been having second thoughts as the day drew nearer, but today when you woke up, your mind briefly shut down and 'rebooted' in a sense. Naturally, if you want to back out of the trial, you can, but these memory issues are not life-threatening, and they will not require we cancel the treatment on our end."

Internally, Jason's frown turned a little ugly.

What she said sort of sounds right, but it also sounds like medical and legal jargon to ensure I can't get out of paying the $20k cancellation fee. They're willing to endanger my life so long as they get their clinical trial!

But unfortunately, Jason had no leverage he could apply. Likely, there were other participants waiting in a queue list, and if he tried finding a way to cancel, he'd only end up stuck with a bill, while Cryotek would replace him immediately.

"I... think I understand." Jason replied. "So I'm still good to go for entering Cryostasis?"

"Yes." Rebecca answered. "However, the fact that you ate food presents a different problem. We're going to have to ask you to wait twelve hours before we can allow you to complete the final steps."

"Oh. Twelve hours." Jason said, feeling slightly gloomy. "It's 9:30 AM. So... I won't be able to get in until 9:30 PM?"

"Right. You can wait out in the lobby, if you like." Rebecca 'helpfully' suggested. "Or you can rent a hotel. But if you eat food again, you'll have to wait until tomorrow to come back. Any further delays beyond that will be considered a cancellation."

"I... I understand." Jason said, feeling his heart sink again. Cryotek were really gunning to make sure he entered Cryostasis. Most likely, there was some sort of government contract involved, or some backroom deal. They needed to ensure the participants joined and the clinical trials were proven safe and effective, at all costs.

After filling out some paperwork and registering his belongings, Jason left the back area of Cryotek and entered the lobby once more, this time only carrying his backpack. He left his duffel bag in the personal belongings lockbox where he would be able to pick them up a year down the road, after his stasis was over.

Slowly, Jason shuffled over to the waiting area seats. He sat down across from the old man again and sighed.

"Problems?" The old man asked.

"No. Quite the opposite. The brown-haired lady said I was fit as a fiddle, so barring the MRI scan revealing a severe neurological issue that sprung up in the last month, I'd have to enter stasis or pay the cancellation fee."

"Hmm. Don't worry about it, kid. I already told you I'd pay that fee if you want out." The old man grunted, his tone dismissive. "Hell, I'll give you a hundred grand to go out and live your best life. Young brat like you ain't got no reason to be here."

Jason looked at the old man in surprise. Was he serious?

"You'd... really do that?"

"I'm worth $212 million. It's pocket change." The old man bragged. "Maybe you've heard of me. Seymour Madrid?"

Jason slowly shook his head. "...Nope. Can't say I have."

"That's fair. I'm the CFO of American Eagle Bank. At least, I was. I tendered my resignation to enter stasis. They put in some thirty-something brat after I left. Place is going to shit anyway. I cashed out before the next housing bubble pops."

Jason blinked. *This guy really doesn't talk like some wealthy banker. I'd never have guessed.*

"Well," Jason finally said, "I'd love the help with paying the cancellation fee, but you don't need to give me any money beyond that. I can figure things out on my own. Somehow, I feel like I'm brimming with ideas for the future, when I wasn't yesterday. No idea why, it's just a strange confidence I have in myself."

"Haha! See, now that's what a young man should say." Seymour chuckled, smiling wide and making his beard and mustache vibrate. "Don't worry about it. I'll even give you two hundred grand, since you're such an upright little bugger. Go and get your stuff, leave the rest to me. I'll make some calls."

Jason smiled at him. "You really don't have to, but... thanks. Nobody's ever helped me like this before."

"I wasn't such a good man in the past." Seymour said, his smile fading a little. "You have to be cutthroat and vicious, stepping on people littler than you, to get ahead in the banking industry. Maybe I'm just trying to make up for my past. Don't think too much on it."

Jason nodded. His smile warmed a little more, and he stood up, thanking Seymour once again.

After that, he strode over to the front desk, to speak to Leeta, but at that moment, something surprising happened.

Cryotek's front doors swished open. Four men wearing government uniforms with *FBI* emblazoned on the front and back entered, their hands on their hip holsters. All of them wore sunglasses and baseball caps, also sporting their agency's name across the front. A pang of alarm went through the lobby as they immediately drew a lot of attention.

The man in the lead held up a walkie-talkie looking device, and it made a pinging noise as he swept it in a wide arc across the lobby, pausing when it started making ping-ping-ping sounds rapid-fire. It only made those noises once he pointed at Jason, so all four men quickly turned to assess the young man.

"It's him?" One of the men asked.

"Code 3-14." The white-haired man in the lead replied. "Blonde hair, blue eyes. Matches the description."

Jason's heart jumped slightly. He didn't know why, but these men were clearly looking for him.

"Sir. Young man." The man in the lead said, approaching Jason with a look of caution on his face. "I'm Agent Silver, with the FBI. I need your identification, please. This is a matter of national security."

The fuck? National security? Jason thought, growing more bewildered by the second.

His hands started to shake as two of the agents move to the sides, slightly encircling him.

Slowly, carefully, with all eyes on the lobby fixed on him, Jason reached into his back pocket, and retrieved his wallet. Then he opened it up and pulled out his state ID and handed it to Silver.

Silver took the ID from him, then he touched the side of his head, where Jason noticed a small cord draping down from his ear.

"Identification acquired. Subject's name is Jason L. Hiro, that's Juliet-Alfa-Sierra-Oscar..."

Silver quickly spelled out Jason's name in the NATO phonetic alphabet, then nodded as someone replied inaudibly in his ear.

"Jason Hiro, we're going to need you to come with us for questioning." Silver said.

"What? Questioning?" Jason asked, feeling slightly scared by this random turn of events. "Have I done something wrong?"

"We need you to come with us for questioning." Silver repeated. "Are you refusing to comply?"

"No, no, I'll comply." Jason said, his legs starting to shake. "I-I just want to know what's going on! I didn't do anything wrong."

"Young man, this is a matter of national security. I am not obliged to speak of the details at this time."

Seeing that there was no way out, Jason reluctantly nodded.

"O-okay. I'll come. But- but my appointment with Cryotek-"

"We'll handle whatever business you had going on today." Silver replied. "Your ID."

He handed Jason's state ID back to him, and Jason shakily stored it back in his wallet, nearly dropping both due to his nerves. A minute later, he strode outside, flanked by two men on both sides, feeling humiliated and fearful for his life.

Luckily, the FBI didn't cuff him. He might have crawled into a hole and died if they did.

I didn't do anything! Jason thought, his eyes trembling with panic. *What the hell is this all about?!*

As he stepped into a van, followed by the four agents, a young blonde woman sat on a bench some distance away. She stared at the happenings, a frown on her face.

"Hmm? This isn't right. I thought he was going to enter the cryopod today? But why would the future change? Is it because of me?"

She bit her lip, unsure whether or not to intervene. As the van started to move, her eyes illuminated with a momentary glow, and she sent a pulse of energy toward it. Having successfully tagged her target, Daisy Hiro stood up and massaged her chin.

"They'd better not hurt him. *American scum*."

Then, she vanished from the spot, disappearing into thin air.

Part 611: Taken

January 13th, 2021. 10:30AM. Somewhere in the woods of Northern Oregon.

Jason sat silently in the back of the FBI van. Two agents sat on his right and left, while Silver and a female agent sat across from him. All of them took their sunglasses off, leaving their faces illuminated by the small light in the back of the windowless van. Jason had no idea who was driving, as he couldn't see them.

The fact he wasn't handcuffed gave the young man precious little reprieve. He trembled from head to toe, trying not to fall into a panic attack. After driving for nearly an hour in absolute silence, with none of the agents saying a word, Jason finally worked up the courage to speak.

"Where... where are you... taking me? I haven't done anything wrong."

"No. You haven't." Silver immediately replied, looking Jason in the eyes. "You're not under arrest, and you have committed no crime. Your existence, however, is a matter of national security. I can't say much more until we arrive at the Haven."

"The Haven?" Jason repeated.

"It's a safe site. We place important individuals inside for their protection."

Jason hesitated.

"If I'm not under arrest... then why all the cloak and dagger? Am I free to leave?"

"No. You're not." Silver replied, his tone neutral. "You are not under arrest, but it is imperative you remain in our custody. Your life is in grave danger. You're lucky we found you before someone else did."

The van vibrated as it drove along at a fast, smooth speed. It hadn't come to a stop for a long time, so Jason estimated they must have been on a highway for a long time. Based on his poor perception of the outside world, he guessed they must be heading east, or perhaps south.

"Who else would be looking for me?" Jason asked, his trembling finally managing to slow down somewhat. Instead of fear, he experienced a surge of confusion. "I'm... nobody. Nobody special, at least."

"That remains to be seen." Silver said, before reaching to his side and pulling out the walkie-talkie-shaped device. He pressed a button and aimed its antenna at Jason, to which it repeated the ping-ping-ping noise from before. "We'll need to conduct a few tests to be sure, but it's likely you're the individual we've been looking for. Just remain quiet for a while longer. We'll arrive soon."

"O...okay." Jason muttered, lowering his head and wondering just what the hell this was all about.

He wasn't anybody.

He was a nobody.

A complete non-entity!

What the hell would the FBI want with a scrawny teenage orphan?

After another thirty or so minutes, the van slowed down drastically. It started taking sharper turns at lower speeds, then its tires crackled as it drove onto what Jason presumed to be a gravel road. It bumped along for a while longer, then it slowed down to the point he could actually hear a songbird singing somewhere outside.

Some voices started speaking.

"...designation... password... Jericho-Niner... yeah... the subject along..."

Jason concentrated as hard as he could, but he could barely make out a few scattered words. The people speaking sounded official and government-like.

Then, the van slowly accelerated again, and the sound of a gate opening buzzed. Jason felt as if it sounded like the gate to a prison, but he couldn't be sure.

A few minutes later, the van came to a final stop. Jason's heart started to beat a little harder as Silver half-stood up, keeping his head low so he wouldn't bang it on the roof.

"Alright. We're here, Jason. Not much longer and you'll get your answers. Come along."

Still flanked by his 'escort', Jason stood up and watched as the back door to the van opened and the noon sunlight poured in, making him wince. He grimaced when he realized all the agents had already put on sunglasses, leaving him the only one with stinging eyes.

Bastards. What, you couldn't give me a pair, too? Cheap fuckers!

Jason cursed the FBI out, then awkwardly stepped out of the back of the van, where he saw a dark-skinned middle-aged woman sitting in a wheelchair, flanked by a protective escort of half a dozen more FBI agents. These men and women all wore SWAT-style body armor, making them much more intimidating than the ones who brought Jason in. They also held military-black assault rifles, though Jason couldn't tell much about what sorts of guns they were.

But then, as Jason looked at them, he confusingly found he did recognize the guns, which was rather odd. He never cared about studying guns in the past, so why would he suddenly know these weapons were AR-15's? More confusingly, these were civilian rifles, not the M4 Carbines commonly wielded by FBI agents.

Before Jason could further break down his situation, the woman in the wheelchair smiled pleasantly and spoke to him.

"Jason Hiro. It's wonderful to meet you. My name is Claire Rothschild."

Jason lowered his eyes to look at her. She was surprisingly attractive, with blonde hair, blue eyes, and dangling rose earrings. She wore a simple white dress with a black overcoat to keep warm on this cold day, and her eyes seemed more innocent than he'd expect from the presumed leader of all these agents.

"Claire." Jason repeated. "Why... am I here? Why have you brought me here?"

"I'm sure Agent Silver told you already, but you're not a prisoner. You are here for your own protection." Claire quickly explained. "You see, we've been searching for you for twelve years now. Why don't you follow me inside, and I'll explain everything?"

Jason blinked.

Twelve years? Why such a specific date? And why him?

He still felt as if he was missing too many pieces of the puzzle to hazard any guesses.

"Alright." He finally said, unsure what else he could add to the conversation besides questions they weren't about to answer in the open sunlight.

Claire touched a control stick on her wheelchair, and it automatically turned around and started driving around the van. Jason followed her, and his eyes wandered around, allowing him to take in the sights.

He had arrived inside a gated compound, surrounded by barbed, and possibly electrified, metal fences. These fences did not consist of one layer, but three, and beyond

them was a massive obsidian-colored wall thirty feet in height. Jason couldn't tell how thick the wall was, but he easily picked out dozens of men and women walking on top of the wall, sniper rifles slung over their backs. Unlike the agents inside the compound, the wall-walkers wore heavy body armor and full tactical gear. Their armor was colored black, likely making it possible for them to blend in and strike from the shadows in case of an enemy attack.

Trees towered above the walls, providing natural camouflage from a distance. Trees also lined the inside of the compound, which Jason found to be slightly confusing. They did cover the entire sky to some degree, making it so planes overhead wouldn't be able to see the compound from above, but they also provided avenues for prisoners to escape by climbing up and jumping over the walls.

Probably not a good idea though. Jason idly thought. *It doesn't seem likely these people were too stupid to figure out something that obvious. They probably have other protections against escapees in place, ones I simply can't see.*

Jason's gaze moved from the trees to a pitch-black building Claire was driving toward. His heart fell into his stomach as the wide, single-story structure gave him a terrifying, ominous feeling.

What the- oh my god! Is this one of those CIA black sites I've heard about? Have they been lying to me this whole time?!

Jason's body started to tremble again, unbidden, as his adrenaline spiked.

Nobody has any rights when they get put into a black site. They strip your rights away and can lie freely to you. Stupid! How could I be so blind? This is clearly a trap! They ARE arresting me, but why? For what purpose?! Do they think I'm a terrorist??

Unfortunately, even if Jason was 100% sure of his hypothesis, he didn't really have any recourse. He was surrounded by heavily armed guards, and he wasn't exactly a fighter. If they came to blows, he'd be knocked out in seconds.

His eyes surreptitiously flicked to the left and the right.

Possible escape options. Silver has a pistol. Is it bio-coded? It might be one of those new 'smart guns'. Stealing it won't give me a weapon. I'd still be outgunned even if I took it.

What about Claire? Maybe I can grab her, threaten her life. She seems important. I might be able to use her as a hostage to free myself.

If I had a melee weapon, I'd feel more assured. Even a straight pipe would give me a fighting chance. If it were long enough, I could wield it like a bo staff, moving fluidly to-NO, what am I even thinking?! I don't have any weapon training! They'd just shoot or tase me if I tried to fight them!

Claire and Jason, along with their entourage, finally arrived at the entrance to the black site. The door opened, and a pair of guards assessed the newcomers. Despite obviously seeming to know who Claire was, they took no chances. They carefully assessed the identity of every individual there, took biometrics data, and double-checked those readings before finally allowing them through.

People here are cautious beyond the realm of normality. Jason noted. *What are they afraid of, shapeshifters? Surely they saw Claire leave the building a few minutes ago. How bizarre...*

Not long afterward, Claire led Jason and a now-smaller contingent of agents deeper into the facility, passing many smartly-dressed government employees, all of whom looked at Jason and whispered things after he passed.

"It's him?"

"Blonde hair, blue eyes. If it's not him, I'll eat my hat."

"He's a bit scrawny."

"Might not have fully Awoken yet. We'll see."

Jason frowned. He tried to ignore these people, but the fact *everyone* seemed to know who he was felt extremely disconcerting.

Finally, Claire led Jason into a small office with a conference table. She gestured to one side, while she and Silver sat on the opposite side. To Jason's surprise, at some point, all the other agents had already peeled off, leaving him alone with just these two.

Wait, is this a chance? Jason thought, his mind instantly sharpening. *It's just the three of us. Even if they have security cameras, I'd only need a few seconds to jump across the table, tackle Silver, grab his gun, then jump up, wrap my arm around Claire's neck and put the gun to her head. With her as my hostage, I could-*

"Jason Hiro." Claire said, smiling prettily. "Would you mind taking a seat? We have a lot to discuss."

Jason blinked. He realized he'd stopped just short of sitting down and was looking around the room a little intensely.

I should wait and hear her out. Jason thought. *Maybe I can get her and Silver to lower their guard before I act.*

He nodded, then sat down. Unfortunately, Silver remained standing. He stood behind Claire and rested one hand on the back of her wheelchair. Jason found the position to be strangely intimate. Perhaps Silver and Claire had a deeper relationship than mere employer-employee...

"So..." Jason said slowly. "Are you going to tell me why you've brought me here?"

"Yes. And I do apologize." Claire said, her smile turning a bit embarrassed. "It wasn't our intention to frighten you. This really is all for your protection. If you are who we think you are, then your life is in grave danger. Especially since you've recently turned eighteen."

"Huh?" Jason grunted. "What does me turning eighteen have to do with anything?"

He frowned, then leaned forward and rested his elbows and arms on the table, giving Claire a perplexed look.

"We've been tracking your activity for years, but were never able to pinpoint your exact location." Claire explains. "You've been a busy boy. Berlin, Paris, Russia, New York, and now even the west coast."

Jason blinked again. In fact, he blinked several times.

"Uh... are you saying... you think I've been to all those places?"

Claire nodded. "Of course! Ah, but before I continue, let me tell you who we are and what our mission is."

She paused.

"As I said before, I am Claire Rothschild, but I do not work for the FBI, and neither does Silver or any of the men and women you saw up to this point. In fact, we aren't part of any three-letter governmental agency."

"So you lied to me?" Jason asks.

"A necessary deception." Claire said without a hint of shame. "We are actually a sort of supernatural defense force. One of humanity's oldest organizations, created thousands of years ago. We exist on every continent and inside every country, save a few who refused entry to us."

"Alright. Who are you?" Jason asked.

"We are the Illuminati." Claire said, still smiling as cheerfully as before.

Jason stared at her.

He became lost for words.

"The... Illuminati? The 'secret' shadow organization literally everyone knows about? You've got to be kidding me."

"We aren't a secret." Claire explains. "Most governments know about us. We're a 'secret' in the sense that we exist in the open, yet hide the truth about ourselves behind conspiracies and lies. It benefits humanity if not too many people take us seriously, you see. But important people in important places know who we are, and our enemies know who we are, so that is all that matters."

Jason nodded slowly.

"Right."

Oh my god. These people are whackos. Jason thought, feeling depressed internally. *A bunch of lunatics. What have I gotten myself involved in?*

Claire didn't seem to notice his sullen expression. She smiled as cheerfully as ever.

"You see, Jason, the Earth is not as you know it. It is actually a melting pot of different cultures and species, all vying for control of our bright blue globe. A brutal war for domination has been playing out over the past hundred-thousand-plus years. The players change, but the game does not. And you, we suspect, are one of the most important players. You are the heir to humanity's mightiest power!"

"Right." Jason repeated, in complete disbelief. "Me. Powerful. Okay."

At this point, Silver spoke. "You seem unconvinced. Jason, our organization is comprised, at the highest levels, by direct descendants of humanity's first Hero, an individual known as Jepthath. He was the Great Illuminator, the one who brought our species out of the darkness into the light. Because of him, we were able to seek salvation

from the angels and demons, and unify ourselves into a cohesive fighting force capable of doing battle against entities much more powerful than ourselves."

"Angels. Demons." Jason repeated. "I guess that tracks."

Jason's immediate dismissal of all this nonsense paused for a moment. He frowned as he suddenly remembered all the strange thoughts he'd been having since he woke up earlier that day.

"Wait... demons... are you saying demons are real?"

"Oh, very real. More real than you know." Claire said. "You probably imagine them as scary Bible stories, or you've seen them depicted in movies and TV shows as evil monsters, but they are not fictional creatures. Their true nature has been hidden from the populace, and they even live in our midst. Demons are everywhere, and if their agents were to find you, they would kill you without hesitation. After all, you are the fated inheritor of Ancestor Jepthath's power."

Before Jason could ask another question, Claire did instead.

"Jason, have you ever performed any strange, unexplained acts of power before? Have you ever made your hands glow, or teleported from place to place, or lifted objects with your mind?"

Jason blinked.

"Uh... is that a serious question?"

"Quite." Claire replied curtly. "Anything at all. Any metaphysical phenomena? Have you experienced anything of the sort? As I said, we've been tracking you for twelve years."

Jason reached up and scratched his head.

"...No? Nothing like that. You said earlier you detected me in Berlin, Paris, and some other places. Uh. I've never been there. I've never even left Oregon."

Claire's smile slipped slightly. She turned her head back to Silver, who once again pulled out the walkie-talkie-looking device, then aimed it at Jason until it let out those odd ping-ping-ping sounds.

"It's definitely you..." Claire said, her smile disappearing. "It has to be you. There can only be one true inheritor of the Heroic Aura. Jason, before we continue, why don't we run some tests? Let's go ahead and fully confirm instead of relying on our Field Detector."

Jason shrugged. At this point, he'd lost his fighting intent and was now simply confused. His fear had turned to disappointment, and even a sort of wry internal laughter.

How could these idiots possibly believe in all that crap about demons and angels? How could they believe he was some special, super powerful 'Hero'? He was just a normal guy.

Though, there were those strange thoughts he'd been having all day long...

Jason waited for a while. He engaged Claire in some minor small-talk, but she refused to answer any further questions until the testing equipment arrived. Eventually, it did. A pair of women entered the conference room, pushing along a rolling cabinet with a helmet of some sort mounted on top.

"This will record your brainwaves." Claire explained. "Just put it on and follow our prompts. We'll test you to see if you have the Heroic Aura after all. Don't worry, it's completely painless."

Doing as Claire asked, Jason put the large metal hat on his head, grimacing at the countless wires sticking out of the top. The two female technicians smiled at him and reassured him there wasn't anything to worry about, so he simply cooperated, curious as to what they would find.

Then the tests began.

First, they slid some papers across the table to Jason.

"Look at each of these images for five seconds, then flip to the next one. We want to record your mental fluctuations."

Jason nodded. He did as they asked. First, there was a picture of a German Shepherd, then a picture of an orange tabby cat, then a picture of a dark-skinned child wearing tribal clothing, possibly from Africa. After that came a series of pictures of men and women from all over the world. Jason glanced up at Claire at one point. She simply smiled, nodded, and mouthed, '*Keep going*'...

At one point, he flipped over to a picture of a beautiful white haired woman, and he stopped to stare at her for a long, long time. The testers frowned, wondering why he hadn't flipped away yet. Jason, however, just couldn't tear his eyes away from the picture. She looked different from something he expected to see, but familiar in a way that made him feel despondent, as if he had lost something precious, something he could never retrieve.

"Jason. Jason." Claire said, pulling him from his thoughts. "Please continue flipping. Unless there's some significance to that woman?"

Jason hesitated. He looked at the white-haired woman for a few moments longer, then reluctantly flipped the page.

"I don't know. I just thought she was... beautiful."

Silver snorted, but didn't say anything.

Jason continued flipping the pages, and when he reached the end, one of the two technicians walked over and whispered something in Claire's ear.

"Mmm. Nothing out of the ordinary, then? Go ahead and save that one picture for him. There's no harm. Alright, Jason, we're going to show you some different pictures. Now that we've established a baseline, these will provide a stronger contrast."

Jason nodded. The next batch of pictures were decidedly different in every conceivable way. Instead of images of animals and people, they were images of mythological monsters, Titans from some unknown religious pantheon, demons, angels, harpies, and many other creatures Jason mentally identified with ease.

Jason frowned at some images. One image in particular gave him serious pause.

Seeing the picture atop the pile, Claire nodded. "That's Satan the Devil. He is the leader of demonkind. Humanity's greatest enemy."

"Why is he so fat?" Jason asked, only to think to himself, *and why does he look so familiar?*

"That's just how he is." Claire said with a shrug.

Jason continued to flip through the images. A surprising number of them seemed extraordinarily familiar to him, as if these were faces he had seen in person, but he could not place when or where.

At the end, Claire received confirmation from the two technicians, who took the helmet off Jason's head and wheeled the device out of the room.

"It's official. You are an inheritor of the Heroic Aura." Claire proclaimed. "When we showed you the images of demons and monsters, the Mana Reader picked up strong reflexive firings of minute amounts of mana. You possess Heroic abilities, and now we simply need to determine what they are."

Jason pursed his lips.

"I'm... a little less skeptical than before. Actually... I might as well just say it. I've been having these strange thoughts all morning, ever since I woke up. It started when I first sat up in bed, and they've only grown stronger as the hours have passed..."

Jason proceeded to speak for much longer than he intended. Claire listened, just as Rebecca did. She and Silver exchanged glances sometimes, particularly when Jason mentioned recognizing many of the demons, angels, and monster species, despite never having seen them in person.

"I'm not going crazy, then?" Jason asked.

"On the contrary. It seems the burst of Heroic Energy we detected at the Cryotek labs was indeed caused by you. Jason, I suspect that you might be a Mentalizer-type Hero."

"A what?" Jason asked.

"Mentalizers are Heroes who possess exceptional brainpower, abilities related to intellect and strategy, or even prophets and farseers." Claire explained. "Perhaps these 'feelings' you've been experiencing are the beginning of your Ascension. Soon, you will wield all your abilities, full and proper."

Everything seemed to click into place. Jason looked down at the picture of the white-haired woman, feeling emotionally attached to her for a reason he couldn't explain.

Was this the cause? Could it be that he was actually a Hero who possessed divine foresight? Would this woman be important to him in some near or far future situation?

It didn't quite feel right.

Jason felt as if she had been important to him in the past. He felt as if he had known 'her' for a lot longer than his short, eighteen-year life implied.

But that was impossible.

"If I was 90% sure before, I'm 100% sure now." Claire said. "Jason, you are the inheritor of the Heroic Aura. If we had not found you, the Angels might have tried to get to you first. That would have been a disaster. The angels are nominally humanity's allies, but Ancestor Jepthath himself passed down a proclamation to his descendants; we must *never* trust Archangel Raphael. He is a liar and a deceiver."

"Naturally," Claire continued, "if the demons had found you, that would be even worse. They might kill you, or they might instead capture you and immobilize you, keeping you alive to ensure the Heroic Aura could not be passed on. That would deprive humanity of a Hero for another thirty, fifty, or even a hundred years. Perhaps that is why no Hero has emerged since the end of the second World War..."

Claire shook her head sadly.

"The last Hero fought for humanity. His name was Harold Whittaker, and he was a German immigrant who came to the United States along with his wife to flee the Nazis. Unfortunately, he volunteered to fight the Nazis, and perished in the final attack. No Hero has appeared since then. The Illuminati were beginning to fear the demons might have found a way to capture the Heroic Aura. If Satan were ever to devour it, his power would rise, and humanity's would plummet to a level that would leave us in despair."

Jason listened to her explanation. It was so outlandish, he felt it looped back around to being sincere. Who could make up a story as ridiculous as this and expect anyone to believe it, unless it was true?

"If I truly am the Hero, chosen by fate or whatever, then what does that mean? I don't think I have any powers... unless I'm a 'prophet' like you said."

"You don't need to worry about all of that. Not for now." Claire said, patting her chest with a sigh of relief. "Jason, we are so fortunate to be the current descendants of the Illuminator who found you. I will make it my life's mission to train you. We will uncover whatever your powers are and seek the best way to elevate your prowess. In fact, you couldn't have come at a more timely moment. As we speak, tensions are rising globally. There are rumors that the demons are planning a major attack on humanity. Their power has grown over the years. They are also starting to fear our rising technological capabilities. The revelations we possessed Atomic Bombs held them back for half a century, but now their Emperors are growing bolder. We fear it is only a matter of time before Satan the Devil launches an attack that could kill tens of millions of humans."

Jason's expression became more severe. If all of this was true and Claire wasn't messing with him, then it was imperative he follow along with her plans.

And if it was all a load of bullshit?

Well... he had already planned to basically kill himself by entering cryostasis.

What did it matter if he did as she asked? If Claire wanted to torture some random orphan and mess with his head, then she truly had a lot of screws loose.

"Alright. I'll go along with all of this." Jason said slowly. "What should we do first?"

Claire smiled sweetly.

"How about we start with some lunch? I haven't eaten since breakfast."

"Err, I told the Cryotek people I wouldn't eat anything-" Jason started to say, before pausing and realizing how ridiculous that statement was. "...Never mind. I guess I could eat a few bites too. What do you guys have here?"

"I think you will be pleasantly surprised." Claire said, turning to roll away from the conference table. "Our amenities are top notch. Come on! I'll show you."

And so, Jason did.

He followed Claire out of the conference room, embarking on the next crazy chapter in his life.

But nobody in that room had the slightest idea how drastically the world was about to change...

Part 612: The Illuminati's Haven

January 13th, 2021. 4PM. Illuminati Haven.

Jason Hiro sat at a table inside a recreation center located two stories underground. To his surprise, there were over a dozen children of varying races and genders playing around, ranging from ages ten to sixteen. There were also some older teenagers supervising them, sometimes joining in on the fun as they played party video games, board games, and card games. There was even a rock wall that one older boy, perhaps aged 17, was climbing.

Plainclothes personnel stood near the entrances, made food, or otherwise played with the children, but Jason knew there were armed guards nearby. Just in case.

As for Jason, he didn't feel any desire to join in. He simply glanced at Claire with a look of curiosity as she parked her wheelchair beside the table.

"All these children possess Heroic potential." Claire explained, gesturing in their direction. "Whenever Heroes rise, Lesser Heroes follow. However, even among the ancient records, there have never been this many humans displaying Heroic potential all at once. Thanks to our advanced Field Trackers, we've been able to find and contain as many humans as possible before other powers could, but we fear we've missed more than a few."

Jason frowned. "What do you mean 'contain'? I thought you said this wasn't a prison?"

"It isn't, Jason. But people with Heroic powers are dangerous. Some, more than others. But any metahuman can be subverted by Russian or Chinese agents. We have to watch out for the claws of other ancient organizations, too, such as the Freemasons, the Rockefellers, and similar birds of a feather. Some of these secret societies are more dangerous than others, and that's to say nothing of the angels and demons. If they obtain Heroically Empowered humans, it could lead to an Era of Disaster."

"The Freemasons and Rockefellers, huh?" Jason asked idly. "Don't tell me I have to watch out for Carnegies and Satanists and all sorts of other obscure groups too."

"Absolutely, you do." Claire nodded. "Don't get me wrong. Some groups are little more than minor cults. Others have vast influences and have stretched their hands deep into

the coffers of powerful governments. All are, to varying degrees, our competitors, if not outright enemies."

Jason slyly glanced at Claire, but he didn't give voice to the thought in his mind.

And she thinks I'm just going to take her word that the 'Illuminati' has my best interests at heart? As if her society is the only true and correct one worth giving my allegiance to...

Instead, Jason pointed at one of the oldest boys, barely any younger than himself.

"So these kids, they're all Heroes like me?"

"Not quite." Claire clarified. "You are a Trueborn Hero. These children only possess the power they do *because* of your existence. They are Lowborn Heroes, with powers weaker than yours. But even so, a minor ability like 'entrancement' could prove dangerous if weaponized against their fellow humans. There are many instances, even recent ones, of humans rising up and secretly using their enhanced abilities to subvert the power structures of our species. These examples all demonstrate the insidious dangers they pose. It is essential that we educate and raise them to properly use their powers for humanity's benefit."

Claire gestured toward the 18 year old Jason indicated before. "Take Jerome, for instance. His ability is simple. He possesses a slightly enhanced physique. He has higher endurance, strength, and agility than someone his age without any training should possess. Right now, it's nothing too amazing. He can't swim faster than world-champion swimmers, he can't lift at the level of the professionals who've trained their whole lives, and he won't be making any new world records in track and field in the near future."

She continued. "But his strength is growing passively, all day, every day. It's slight, but definitely noticeable when we test him each week. He doesn't need to train. He doesn't need to work out. By simply existing, Jerome grows stronger every day."

"Then what if he works out?" Jason asks.

"He does do that." Claire answered. "It accelerates his growth, creating compound returns over time. If he trains day in and day out, I believe it won't be more than two or three years before he reaches the apex of what ordinary humans can achieve in most physical fields. And after that? He'll just keep growing stronger. Perhaps someday, he'll be able to fight and kill Demon Emperors with his physical abilities alone."

"Are Demon Emperors strong?" Jason asked.

"All demons are stronger than humans, depending on how you measure strength." Claire explained. "To understand why, you need to understand the demon maturation cycle."

"First," she continued, "demons are born from Broodmothers, which are giant ant-queen-like demonesses who spawn little creatures known as Imps. Imps are weak and stupid, but they can kill human children with ease. In that way, demon newborns are much stronger than human ones, though they pose little threat to our adults."

"Next, Imps can evolve after devouring a human soul. They can either become Grunts, or become Lowborn, which look extremely similar to human children and teenagers, minus the red skin and other demonic features."

Jason raised an eyebrow. "They eat souls?"

"Yes, and it grants them immense power." Claire explained. "They have an entire system in Hell for converting dead humans into souls, but that isn't important for right now. What matters is that you understand the different ranks of demons."

Seeing Jason's silent nod, Claire continued to speak.

"Demon Grunts come in all different types. There are Burners, Brutes, Seers, Warpers, and other sorts of specialized demons possessing one singular, holistic ability. This ability is often what defines their future growth after evolving to the next ranks. But Demon Lowborn are interesting, because they can vary quite drastically in their capabilities. Grunts and Lowborn can both evolve to the rank of Demon Lord by devouring ten human souls."

"Are Lowborn stronger than Grunts?" Jason asked.

"Not... exactly. As I said, their capabilities vary. Some Lowborn possess fine control of fire, lightning, hemokinesis, and other metaphysical powers. Some possess no abilities whatsoever! Unfortunately for those types, they are often seen as trash and end up becoming servants and slaves for higher ranking demons."

She shook her head before continuing. "In any case, an unarmed human will lose to a Demon Grunt or Lowborn all of the time. With modern weapons and body armor, the equation flips. An ordinary police officer can kill most Lowborn with ease, though the

more extreme Grunts, such as the Brutes, will require specialized task forces to take them down."

"Seems some demons have all the genetic luck." Jason muttered.

"Demon society is anything but fair." Claire said with a sigh. "Even so, demons can still get ahead if they are psychopathic enough and willing to kill beyond what their superiors command."

"Anyway, after Grunts are Demon Lords. Demons need to consume ten human souls to become Lords, and at that point, they become serious threats to ordinary human forces. One Demon Lord cannot waltz into a military base and wreak havoc, but they can certainly cause chaos in the streets of major cities, leaving tens or even hundreds dead. Some Demon Lords in the past have even deliberately raced to kill as many humans as possible, hoping to swallow their souls and ascend to the next rank."

"You seem like you're about to tell me that doesn't usually work out." Jason says.

"It doesn't." Claire confirms. "Because, you see, Demon Lords require 1,000 souls to become Demon Barons. And let me tell you, Demon Barons are extremely dangerous. Each one typically possesses a body stronger than peak humans. Some can grab tanks and throw them through the air, or use psychic powers to level buildings. They can unleash lightning storms that disable all electric-based devices and weaponry, and so on. You absolutely must not trifle with Demon Barons. Each one is a powerhouse that requires a military platoon to deal with."

Jason's expression became unsightly. "What's next? Emperor?"

"No. After Barons are Dukes." Claire answered. "Dukes are unbelievably powerful. We haven't even made it to the level of Emperors yet, and already Dukes should cause you to suffer some sleepless nights. Humanity's only good fortune is that the number of Dukes in existence are estimated to be under five hundred, but each one of them is a city-level powerhouse. A single Duke, if angered, could potentially wipe Tokyo off the map. They could glass the skyscrapers, vaporize humans en-masse, and cause immense pain and suffering."

She continues. "We are fortunate that the atomic bombs scared the demons away from causing any mass casualty events in the past seventy years, but during World War II, when our weapons were more primitive, Demon Dukes appeared infrequently and killed tens of thousands of our allied soldiers."

"I guess that means the Nazis were working alongside the demons then..." Jason muttered, looking away. "Really explains a lot."

Claire cocked her head. "No? The Nazis were a human element of evil. They were led by a corrupt tyrant who sought power for his own ends, plain and simple. Sometimes, humans can be just as vile to each other as demons are to us."

"Oh! That tracks too." Jason said, nodding.

Claire nodded back. "Anyway, to become a Duke, a Demon Baron must consume 100,000 human souls. This number is simply infeasible, outside a massive attack on humanity. For that reason, Demon Dukes are made, not born. One cannot become a Demon Duke by wantonly slaughtering humans. They can only do so if the true rulers of demonkind grant them Soul Pills, which contain the condensed essence of human souls. After ingesting enough of those, they will Ascend to Duke."

She sighs. "And then, after Duke, we have... Emperors. To become an Emperor, a demon need only ingest 1,000,000 souls. Considering the amount of power they obtain, this is a small price to pay, but the vast number of demons in Hell clamoring for their evolution ensures Demon Emperors cannot rise too often. Unfortunately, the boom in human population during the last two centuries has given demons all sorts of opportunities to grow their power. There are nearly twice as many Emperors in the modern day as there were before the 1700's, to say nothing of the overall demon population."

"It's kind of weird." Jason said. "Imps need 1 soul to evolve, then 10, then 1,000, then 100,000, than 1,000,000. Why is it a soul multiplier of 10, 100, 100, then 10 again??"

Claire shrugged. "That's just how it is. Considering demons cannot evolve beyond the Rank of Emperor, we assume one million souls is the saturation point. Any souls beyond one million are useless."

She paused.

"In any case, Demon Emperors are the final, and the most powerful of all foes. In total, there are perhaps twenty Emperors in existence across all the Seven Hells, though we must account for the possibility of Emperors who evolved in secret, or Emperors whose ascendencies were kept hidden from us by the demons. It is never wise to reveal all your cards to your enemies, so we always assume there are more demons we do not know of. Emperors, by themselves, can wipe out entire human armies. Each one has their own

special abilities that make them extremely difficult to suppress, let alone kill. In the past, only Trueborn Heroes have been able to reliably go toe-to-toe with these behemoths."

"So if there's no Hero, humanity is just screwed?" Jason asks.

"Actually..."

Claire pursed her lips. Then she looked into the distance, in the general direction of the children playing.

"The angels are our enemies. But they are also our allies. Woe be unto me to say this, but the angels are a necessary evil. Their leaders, the Archangels, possess enough power to stand against the Demon Emperors, at least to some extent. And aside from the Angels, we also have allies among the Titans. Some of those Titans are actually humanity's strongest pillars to lean upon, especially when a given Era does not have a Hero at its forefront."

"Titans?" Jason asks.

"Gods, as far as humans remember them." Claire explains. "Entities towering tens, even hundreds of feet tall. A Titan's height is proportional to their strength. The largest ones are more than capable of standing against one or more Demon Emperors with ease. They are not invincible, but they can give humanity a fighting chance if the demons one day rise up in unison to attack on all fronts."

Claire patted her legs and sighed deeply.

"It is imperative that you master your psychic powers quickly, Jason. Seers may not possess the strongest offensive or defensive abilities, but you can still prove instrumental in collecting intelligence on the demon's movements. If we know what they are doing, we can anticipate their attacks and prepare ahead of time."

"Do we even know my powers are psychic at all?" Jason asks doubtfully. "What if I can shoot fireballs or lightning or something?"

"Then we will determine that next. Come with me." Claire said, turning her wheelchair away from the table.

Jason nodded, then stood up and followed after her.

A few minutes later, after riding the Haven's elevator several floors downward, the two of them emerged into a pristine white hallway with mirrors in all the corners, allowing Jason to see armed guards up around the bend, no matter which direction he looked.

"The Testing Center is where we take individuals who possess Heroic potential and test them to discover the full extent of their abilities. At this point, I'll have to see you off. Doctor Eliezer Redbaum will be the one to test you today."

"I see. Then, thank you, Claire." Jason said, gently squeezing her shoulder. "This has made me feel a lot more assured about what I need to do, moving forward."

"It is my pleasure to serve this generation's Hero." Claire said, nodding her head lightly while touching his hand. "If you have any further questions, just ask anyone here to call me and I'll come running."

"Or rolling." Jason said, jokingly pointing at her wheelchair with his thumb.

"Yes, or 'rolling'." Claire replied with a bemused smile.

She didn't take his joke badly, which made him feel better.

Not long after, Jason and Claire separated, and a tall lanky man with narrow metal glasses stepped out of an office up ahead. His hair was curly and somewhat messy, making him look the part of a nutty professor. His pale skin made it seem as if he hadn't stepped out into sunlight in months, perhaps even years. He looked a little ghoulish, in Jason's eyes.

"Ah, Mister Hiro? How good to meet you!" Eliezer Redbaum said, enthusiastically shaking Jason's hand with an excited grin. He almost seemed like a kid who'd unwrapped the newest game console on Christmas. "To think I'd finally meet this generation's Hero! How does it feel to be the Chosen One? To be the luckiest human on Earth out of all the billions of others?"

Jason blinked. "The Chosen One, huh? I hadn't really been thinking about it like that. All this stuff about angels and demons seems rather dire. I feel as if a heavy load has been placed on my back. It's not particularly enjoyable."

"Ah, that's Claire for you! All doom and gloom, but with a pretty smile to make it a little more appetizing!" Eliezer chirped. "But never mind all that. This is the FUN part, Jason! Now you get to find out just what sort of abilities you have! Your mana output is higher than anyone else here, so it's certain you're the real deal!"

Eliezer paused for half a breath, then gestured behind himself. "Come along, come along! In here, we'll start testing all the known abilities to see what you can do."

Jason's mood did perk up a bit. "You've tested many people before me?"

"This institute was founded hundreds of years ago, by the great Madam Mildred!" Eliezer explained, as he and Jason entered the testing room. "Before that, we simply located Heroes and protected them, but we had no formal library of known abilities. Lady Mildred was truly a genius! She created a whole division focused on cataloging every known demon, angel, and Hero power to try to match newly discovered Heroes to all their abilities. This allowed us to discover hidden powers inside a few Trueborn Heroes who otherwise might have missed them. Can you imagine only knowing you can lift ten-ton objects, but not that you could fly? What a pity it would be to overlook such a useful ability!"

Jason looked around the testing room. Inside, there were Tesla coils sparking electricity between them, a series of burners outputting different colored flames, vats filled with multiple unique types of liquid, and countless other things he could hardly make sense of. Aside from Eliezer, there were a half-dozen other scientists, all looking at Jason with expressions of adoration.

Their gazes... made him feel a little uncomfortable. He felt as if he'd become an object of worship, leaving his humanity behind in the process.

"Come, come, have a seat." Eliezer said, pushing his glasses up his nose.

The thirty-something year old man quickly darted to a nearby table, then smoothly wheeled it over to Jason. He placed two chairs down, one on each side, then took a seat across from Jason while holding a book in his hand. He held up the book so Jason could only see the cover, which was entirely blank, then he opened it up.

"Alright, the report states that you might possess some form of precognition. This first test will assess if that is the case. To start, what is the first image on page one?"

Jason blinked. "The first page? Inside the book? I can't see it."

"Perhaps not with your eyes, but look *inside* yourself. Try to touch upon your mind's eye, Jason." Eliezer said. "Look not at the book, but at the fabric of reality surrounding it. Barring that, try to read my mind and see the image I see. Alternately, maybe you can peer a few seconds into the future, witnessing when I turn the book around to show you the image?"

Jason frowned. He closed his eyes and concentrated, then he opened them again. He squinted. He pressed his lips together until he metaphorically felt smoke coming from his ears.

"...Nothing." Jason finally said.

"Ah, I see. Well, it's a picture of an orange tabby cat." Eliezer said, turning the book to show Jason. He turned the book back around. "Alright, now that you understand the general theme of the book, perhaps you can guess the picture on the second page. What could it be?"

Jason once again frowned. He closed his eyes and concentrated, trying to tap into something deep within his psyche...

But ten minutes later, Eliezer closed the book and set it on the table.

"I'm sorry." Jason said, feeling slightly guilty.

"It's no matter. You possess the Heroic Aura, so you absolutely must have a Heroic power. There's no reason to feel glum, my boy. We'll just have to keep testing! Follow me over here, if you'd please."

Eliezer led Jason over to a nearby table, one with multiple different flames jetting upward a few inches, all of them glowing a variety colors.

"These flames are all attuned to various levels of heat. The colors are a result of how hot they burn." Eliezer explained. "Let's see if you possess any pyrokinetic capabilities. Try reaching out and manipulating the first flame. It's the weakest one and should pose no problem."

Jason smiled awkwardly, but he held no belief he had any fire-related powers. Something told him this was a total waste of time.

Still, he tried. And he tried some more.

Minutes later, this test, too, concluded with a complete failure.

"Say... you guys aren't, like, *fucking with me*? Are you?" Jason asked doubtfully. "This isn't all just a bunch of mumbo-jumbo? How do I know there are people who have magical powers? I've pretty much been taking you at your word, here."

Eliezer cocked his head. "Oh? Claire didn't give you a demonstration? Let's rectify that."

He motioned to one of the other scientists, a lady with curly blonde hair. "Leslie, can you go ahead and fetch Brian for me? Let's put on a little show for Jason here."

"Sure! Just give me a moment." Leslie replied.

She left the room, and Jason engaged Eliezer in some small talk until she returned with a 16-year-old boy in tow. The boy looked clean-cut, with swept-back black hair. He even wore an excellently-fitting suit. When he smiled at Jason, the Wordsmith found that he looked a little familiar somehow, but he couldn't understand why his brain registered the similarities.

"Brian, this is Jason Hiro, the Trueborn Hero of our generation. And Jason, this is Brian Bozzard, our resident firecracker. He's a pyrokinetic with a flair for the snazzy. His father is actually an oil baron from the south coast, and Brian here caused a little *accident* with his powers when they first awakened."

Brian looked away awkwardly for a moment, but quickly reverted back to his charming smile after recovering his bearings. "Good day, Jason. Yes, ah, there was a bit of a mishap. I may have accidentally burned one of our mansions down... ahaha... but luckily, we managed to evacuate everyone in time. Father was sure to clean up the rubble quickly, and we moved to our summer home for a few months. Then these splendid researchers picked me up before the public could learn of my abilities. That was a year ago, and the rest is history."

Jason bobbed his head, then smiled. "It's good to meet you then, Brian. So, you manipulate flames? Can you show me?"

"Most certainly! Thanks to the efforts of the Illuminati, I've mastered my abilities, but they continue to grow more formidable day by day. Here, take a look."

Jason expected Brian to walk over to the burners and extract fire from them, but to his surprise, the teenager instead ignited an orb of flame in his palm and expanded it to the size of a softball, then held it in place for a few moments, smirking at Jason's wide-eyed expression.

"How about that? Still a skeptic? Still think magic is a bunch of 'mumbo jumbo'? I assure you, dear Jason, that is not the case! My abilities are the real deal!"

Brian absorbed the fireball back into his hand harmlessly, then he took off his suit's overcoat and handed it to one of the assistant researchers before walking into a nearby testing chamber, where he proceeded to summon and fling fireball after fireball, blasting the reinforced wall with a barrage of them, unleashing a stream of wide flames, then a concentrated beam of fire afterward.

"Haaah!! Hahaha, how about that, eh, Jason? Are you impressed yet?"

"Definitely impressed!" Jason exclaimed, before turning to Eliezer. "There really is such a thing as magic! So that must mean I have magic of my own, right?"

"Certainly!" Eliezer replied. "I've yet to hear of a Trueborn Hero with no powers at all. I'm sure if we keep testing, we'll uncover your hidden potential. Alright, thank you for coming down here, Brian. We'll be sending Jason back up later. The two of you can talk then. Maybe you'll even become fast friends!"

Brian emerged from the testing room with a smile on his face. After putting his coat back on, he bowed slightly. "I look forward to making the acquaintance of the Trueborn! I've been waiting to hear about him, after seeing the results of his exploits. Jason, do be a good man and drop by later? I'll introduce you to some of the girls."

Jason chuckled softly. "Haha... thanks for the offer. I'll drop by, but there's no need to play matchmaker. I'm a faithful man. And the girls here all seem a bit young for me."

"A bit young?" Brian asked, raising an eyebrow. "A few of them are eighteen already. You're eighteen too, right? And what's that about being faithful? Don't tell me you're married already?"

Jason hesitated. "Yeah I'm- well no, I'm not married. I think. *Right*, I'm not married yet. Sorry, don't know why I said that before... and I'm only eighteen, yeah."

Eliezer and Leslie exchanged glances, raising their own eyebrows at Jason's strange words. Eliezer made a mental note to look into whether or not Jason had any marital attachments. It wouldn't be good for him to leave behind a secret wife out there, looking for him, asking difficult questions...

Brian left, and Jason remained behind. Eliezer sat the young man down, smiling at his energetic expression.

"Well, you seem a bit more eager to uncover your Heroic powers. No longer a skeptic, I assume?" Eliezer asked.

"I'm ready. Hit me with all your tests." Jason answered.

"Okay then. Let's go ahead and continue where we left off." Eliezer said. "After fire manipulation, we'll try testing the other classical elements of water, earth, wind, light, dark, yin and yang, and several others. Then we'll test out your technological capabilities, then your physical attributes."

"Can we start with the physical ones?" Jason asked.

"Hmm... well, the order doesn't really matter. I suppose so. Let's start by testing how much weight you can bench press, how many pull-ups you can do, your running speed, your stamina, and other such things. Having an exhaustive physical examination done before the metaphysical stuff is beneficial too."

* * *

Hours later, Jason sat on a bench, tired as hell. He wheezed and gasped for breath, looking between the researchers a short distance away as they graded his... less than impressive physical stats.

Eliezer came over to him, a mild look of disappointment on his face. "Well, you're no Jerome, that's for sure. You under-performed compared to the average 18 year old Asian-American, with strength and stamina much lower than anticipated. If you're a physical-type Hero, your abilities have yet to come in. How about you rest for a bit, and we'll bring the combat instructor inside? He can test you on your ability to learn martial arts."

"If my physical strength sucks, then what's the point of that?" Jason asked.

"Don't be so quick to judge." Eliezer said with a chuckle. "Several Heroes, Trueborn and Lowborn, have been known as masters of physical combat. Buddha was the most noteworthy, as he was known as the God of Combat. He didn't even have to fight demons to kill them, but when he did fight, he left them broken and despondent. His physical strength wasn't impressive at all, but he mastered countless forms of martial arts, weapon-wielding, and many other such things. There's always a chance you could become like him, given time!"

Jason stuck out his lower lip and nodded, in a *not bad* sort of way. "Yeah, that could be good. Alright, give me a bit and I'll go in there. Can I have some water?"

"Sure thing. In fact, why don't we get you a couple sandwiches?" Eliezer asked. "You've been working hard for a few hours now. It'll be bedtime in the Haven soon, so we'll get you up to your room when the time comes."

"Sure. Thanks." Jason answered.

After a bit more time passed, and Jason rejuvenated his somewhat tired body, he stepped into a new training arena with an older man in his forties. The man appeared to be a gruff, American military-type with tattoos on his face, a shaved head, and a long beard.

"We'll start with some simple sparring." The man said, as he reached to his side and grabbed a bo staff from some weapons on the wall. The entire staff was covered in heavy padding to deaden the blows and inflict as little material damage as possible. At the same time, the instructor grabbed a staff of his own. "I'm Lieutenant Dobson, former Marine. Joined the Illuminati as their external combat advisor. Don't worry, kid, I'll take it easy on you. You just follow along with my commands and see what you can pick up."

Jason took the bo staff from Dobson. At the same time, his eyes metaphorically flashed as he rapidly analyzed the weapon's weight and length, estimating its reach and other critical parameters that would affect his performance.

"The first thing to do-" Dobson started to say, before pausing to stare in bewilderment as Jason started rapidly spinning and twirling the staff around his body.

Not just Dobson, but the other scientists outside. Eliezer's mouth gaped open as he watched while Jason started spinning the staff around his body with a level of fluidity even Dobson would struggle to replicate! Dobson himself had a solid but fundamentally shallow knowledge of how to wield over a dozen weapon types, and he could immediately tell Jason was not an amateur in the slightest.

"What the..." Dobson said, pausing to scratch his head. "Kid, are you one of those national prodigies who has been training for a karate competition since you were six, or something?"

Jason instantly brought the revolution of his staff to a stop by slamming its butt on the ground. "No. I don't know how I'm able to do this. It just... feels natural to me. Like I've practiced for years, or something."

Dobson immediately sobered up his expression. He stopped looking at Jason like an inexperienced youth, as he'd already faced a couple of kids who surprised him during the last couple of years.

"Hmm. Never mind what I was saying before. I'm going to focus entirely on defending myself. Try to get me onto the ground, and we'll see what you know from there."

"Sounds good." Jason said, looking at the older man confidently. "We'll do that, then."

Jason suddenly lunged forward, spinning the bo staff around his body. He revolved it from back to front, and Dobson spun his staff into position, blocking the attack.

But the instant Jason's staff connected, it fluidly bounced away, spun behind his body, and snapped toward Dobson from the opposite direction.

Shit! He's fast! Dobson thought, moving to block the attack, but failing to react quickly enough. He was rewarded with a light *thump* against his ribs, but luckily, Jason's padded staff didn't hurt him.

Immediately, Dobson raised Jason's threat level immensely. *My god! He's a natural! I've never seen talent like this! Is this the power of this generation's Trueborn?!*

In the other room, behind the plexiglass, Eliezer's jaw dropped even further. He could hardly believe his eyes.

Over the next two minutes, Jason began to systematically dismantle Dobson's defenses. He frowned, wondering why his combat instructor was so slow to adapt to his relatively basic attack patterns. Jason barely even put effort into his attacks, yet he was able to strike Dobson time after time after time!

Thankfully, the padded staff prevented Dobson from suffering any injuries, but after a while, the rhythmic smacking of his helmeted face, his ribs, his thighs, and even his legs started to hurt a little.

"Alright. Alright! I yield!" Doson exclaimed, quickly taking a few steps back.

Jason immediately brought his bo staff to a stop by planting its butt on the ground. He scratched his head.

"...Is there anyone other than you here who is talented with the bo staff? Could we bring in someone who's more... formidable?"

"I..." Dobson stammered, lowering his head in shame.

To think this teenager would have beat me black and blue if we weren't using training staffs. He's a monster!

"Jason," Eliezer said, recovering from his shock, "we can bring in an external instructor later. For now, why don't you try switching to another weapon type?"

"Sure." Jason replied. He put the staff back, then glanced at Dobson. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine!" Dobson sputtered, slightly annoyed by the question. "Let's try sparring with swords. I'm more confident in my swordplay anyway. I trained with the Knights Templar for two years over in England."

"Whoa, they sound impressive!" Jason said, genuinely surprised by Dobson's statement.

Regaining a little bit of his adult authority, Dobson quickly puffed out his chest a little. "I'll say this; I wasn't much compared to the knights, but I learned to hold my own. If you ever want to learn peerless swordplay, their masters are the best of the best!"

"I'll keep that in mind." Jason said.

He and Dobson switched to holding wooden shortswords in their dominant hands, and a shield in their off-hands. Dobson also took the initiative to put on stronger body armor.

"Like before, I'll defend while you attack." Dobson said, now speaking through a heavier helmet. Unlike with the bo staffs, the wooden swords were not padded and could cause painful injuries if they struck bones or vital organs.

A few moments later, Jason attacked! This time, Eliezer and the others became truly filled with awe.

Jason's sword snapped forward with the speed of a cobra. He feinted left sometimes, and right others. He swept at Dobson's legs and kept him guessing, but most importantly, he struck Dobson's body armor time after time, leaving Dobson unable to counter him at all!

Dobson at least managed to deflect more of Jason's attacks thanks to being able to defend both sides of his body with his sword and shield. But unfortunately, due to the sword's lighter weight, Jason was able to speed up his attacks, cutting, chopping, and stabbing at vulnerable locations time after time!

"Damn! Shit! Ouch!" Dobson cursed, feeling a mixture of awe at Jason's skills and sheer disappointment in his own. *Even if this brat trained with the sword since he emerged from the womb, he shouldn't be this good! I feel like a chump compared to him! What the hell??*

Through his actions, Jason casually threw Dobson's earlier bragging about being trained by the Knights Templar back in his face. Dobson couldn't help feeling stifled by now. If Jason was just as talented with other types of weapons, Dobson would really be out of luck! Swords and staffs were his bread and butter, and his other weapon masteries were far shallower.

Finally, Dobson gave up once again, yielding to Jason's skill.

"G-good fight." Dobson said, wanting to puke blood from shame.

"Were you holding back the whole time?" Jason asked, confused. "I kept thinking you were making deliberate openings so I'd rush in and you'd punish me, but you never did..."

"Holding back?!" Dobson sputtered. "Who do you think I am, the great Buddha himself? You're a monster, kid! An absolute monster! If you've never actually trained before in your life, then color me impressed. You're clearly a combat specialist with a bright future ahead of you."

Jason smiled. "Well, thanks for the assist. I'm pretty tired now, so maybe we can pick up where we left off tomorrow."

"Yeah. We'll try other types of weapons, then." Dobson said, before adding, "And I'll call some people I know, see if we can get more skilled teachers in here. I'm nowhere near your level."

Jason shook Dobson's hand, and they went their separate ways.

After he exited the training area and the ex-marine went his own way, Jason turned to look at Eliezer expectantly.

"I don't know if you're a Seer, but you're absolutely a potential combat god." Eliezer said, his expression solemn. "The skills you just displayed were terrifying. You're a natural. If we focus on training your body to match your combat strengths, you'll become capable of taking down Barons single-handedly. Most demons are lazy bastards with middling combat skills. They rely on brute force and their raw strength to overpower weaker opponents. If you can dismantle them with your weapon skills, you might even become as fearsome as the Hero-King Arthur himself."

Jason yawned. "Well, that sounds exciting. But for now, I'm exhausted. Mind showing me to my room?"

Eliezer shook his head and chuckled. "I've never seen someone tire themselves out by beating someone else's ass. Alright. I'll have Leslie take you up to your room. Leslie, would you be a dear? I need to make some phone calls and update Miss Rothschild on our prodigy here."

"It would be my pleasure." Leslie said, smiling cheerfully at Jason.

Twenty minutes later, she led the young man up to his room. They opened the door, and Jason found a surprisingly large apartment much bigger than the one he owned before, with a comfortable-looking king-sized bed covered in multiple comforters, a TV with several game systems plugged into it, and a computer much fancier than anything Jason had owned before.

"This is Room 1A, the first in all the dorms." Leslie explained. "As the Trueborn, you get the best housing here, but the other kids aren't far behind. We want all our talents to be comfortable. You can access the internet if you want, but outside communications are strictly monitored. This is a top secret location after all, and all your computer activity will be logged."

She glanced at him and coughed. "If you, ahem, look up any adult content... just be aware our people will be watching. Since you're over 18, we won't stop you, but..."

"Right, right. I get it." Jason said, massaging his forehead. "Point being; I'm being watched."

"When you say it like that, it sounds a bit dystopian. We only want to ensure your safety." Leslie quickly clarified. "There is a demon named Ose who is her species' foremost, and currently *only* technomancer. She is adept at monitoring the entire internet, and can easily uncover crucial clues about targets once she becomes aware of them. You *must* beware 'Ghost.' She is extremely dangerous and considered a Class S modern threat. We're lucky she is only a Baron and the other Emperors don't value her talents highly enough, or humanity would be in grave danger of having all our technology subverted."

Jason nodded. It didn't seem like Leslie was making this information up, and he didn't want to discount her fears.

"Noted. I'll mind my business, then. I'm gonna take a shower, then hit the hay."

"Wonderful. Have a great night, Jason." Leslie said, before waving to him and closing the door.

Some time later, Jason washed the grime off his body, stumbled over to his bed, and flopped onto it, sagging into its warm embrace with a moan of pleasure. It was possibly the most comfortable thing he'd ever laid on.

Before long, he drifted off to sleep.

Then, he began to experience the *strangest* of dreams…

Part 613: Back to the Future

Inside the Labyrinth Core, Demon Deities Melody, Yardrat, Auger, and Kristoff continue to remain standing in place, their feet adhered to the ceiling. With the low spirits of the humans having been uplifted by the return of Jason Hiro, the three Deities currently positioning themselves as humanity's enemies also find themselves in an awkward spot. It would be one thing if the Wordsmith was dead. They could continue to bully the humans and taunt Melody repeatedly. But with him still alive, all their plans have to change, and nobody is more cognizant of this fact than Auger himself.

The former Emperor strokes his goatee thoughtfully, his aged face making him appear as old and decrepit as Agares once did. Even so, age is merely a mirage for the demons. Since they are all immortal, any signs of 'aging' are likely a result of overextending their life-force by overusing their powers. Naturally, they can still die from this, but few demon elites have ever been so stupid as to die in this way.

"So." Melody says, smiling at the other Deities. "What were you saying earlier? I seem to have forgotten. Perhaps you can refresh my memory?"

Kristoff sighs. "Sharmur is yours. Do as you see fit with it. We will not interfere. Consider your pet humans *fortunate* that their protector returned, alive and well."

"How did he survive, anyway?" Yardrat asks, looking at Melody suspiciously. "Did he die and then revive? If so, how? The Lazarus Tower fell before anything else. The Psions would not be so stupid as to leave it standing."

Melody shrugs. "The Wordsmith is smarter than you think. He probably faked his death, just to see what would happen."

"No." Auger counters. "I very much doubt that. Why would he allow Tarus II to be blown up? If he's as smart as you say, he would surely have protected it from the Psions. I believe he *did* die, then he revived. It might explain how Beelzebub became a Demon Deity. Perhaps Beelzebub Ascended through some pre-planned mechanism between the two of them."

"Beelzebub does have the ability to revive from death endlessly." Yardrat points out. "The little bastard is an unkillable cockroach. He is likely the strongest Cosmic in the

Milky Way at this point. Even if Founder Dosena had not met such a terrible fate, I doubt she would be able to outlast a truly immortal Cosmic in a battle of endurance."

Melody's smile turns to a slight frown. Even she has no idea how Jason came back to life, but based on the other Deities' words, they seem to be thinking Beelzebub's power had something to do with it.

Their guesses certainly don't seem implausible. Once he ascended to a Cosmic, all bets were off the table. Beelzebub could already regenerate from death within seconds as a mere Emperor. Surely, as a Cosmic, it wouldn't be outside the realm of possibility for him to resurrect other fallen entities, including the Wordsmith.

If so, then the loss of the Lazarus Tower won't affect humanity nearly as adversely as the demons expected. Beelzebub might even be reviving humans en-masse as they speak!

The other Deities wear troubled expressions. This at least gives Melody a hint of delight. The fact they're visibly alarmed by Beelzebub's power means they won't dare act too far out of line. They have to consider what sort of swift and violent retaliation he might bring about if they piss him off.

"You know," Melody says playfully, "while you lot bitch on and on about the humans, it occurs to me... the Volgrim don't have a Middle Cosmic protecting them anymore. Isn't that interesting?"

Auger sneers. "Who knows what measures those ancient monsters have at their disposal? Even if they lack a Middle Cosmic, they might be able to uplift a High Psion to the position quicker than we expect. Their 'weakness' could easily be a charade. For Founder Dosena to so foolishly trigger an Akashic backlash despite knowing the price she'd have to pay, it makes one's mind wander. We'll worry about the Volgrim later. We still have the Plague to deal with."

"Indeed, that we do." Melody says, putting this discussion to rest. She glances down at the humans, noting the distinct split between people traveling to Pixiv and people traveling to Sharmur. "We're all friends here, right? So I can speak to you honestly?"

Auger smirks, but says nothing to refute her words. He simply nods.

"What happened at Maiura was a wake-up call." Melody says solemnly. "Forget your feelings toward the humans for a moment. Do you understand just how fucked we are? Humans, demons, and Volgrim alike. The Plague is not a mindless organism hellbent on

feeding. It is an intelligent super-entity capable of thoughtful planning and deception. It waited to reveal its mass-psionic capability until the moment humanity was least able to counter it. It nearly swallowed another Executor. The Kolvaxors it now possesses are Low Cosmics that fight like Bottom Cosmics but have bodies as durable as Middle Cosmics. If those Kolvaxors come for Sharmur, Yardris, Hell Harbor, or any of demonkind's other worlds, none of you will be able to resist. Being a Middle Cosmic means nothing in the face of such massed power."

Her words cause the other Deities to cease their smirking and gloating.

Indeed, every word she speaks is 100% correct. Their petty disputes mean nothing in the face of this galaxy consuming super-organism.

"Speak plainly." Kristoff says. "What are you proposing? A ceasefire? A treaty?"

"Why not? We only have to deal with Jason Hiro now. Not Hope, and not Neil Adams." Melody points out. "Jason wants all the Sentients to unite against the Plague. He has already demonstrated his willingness to bolster demonkind's members."

"That was *before* the Volgrim betrayed him." Yardrat points out. "We have no idea what sort of headspace he's in now. You saw how panicked he was earlier? He was practically frantic with fear, looking for his wife. We can't assume the old status quo will remain."

"You should at least entertain the idea." Melody says. "In fact- hmm?"

She pauses, then looks off into the distance, her cosmic vision piercing the Labyrinth walls. At the same time, the other Deities also look in that direction as well.

"Wait, is that…?" Kristoff starts to ask.

"It is." Auger answers, his expression darkening.

Inside the Labyrinth Core, the humans continued moving through the two portals to Pixiv and Sharmur in a relatively calm and orderly manner. Naturally, even with the Wordsmith having returned, many people were broken-hearted and despondent. A massive number of humans perished on Maiura and Tarus II, leaving only 180,000 alive in Realspace. Among those, roughly 120,000 chose to go to Sharmur, while 60,000 migrated to Pixiv. This alone showed how Jason's survival affected the survivors, giving a bit of spirit to those who would rather thrive under his future rule.

Among the people choosing to migrate to Sharmur is a surprising pair of faces; Cassiel and Soleil. The two angels naturally disguise themselves as ordinary humans, but they opt to go to the demon-controlled world of Sharmur rather than the friendlier world of Pixiv.

"I must protest..." Soleil hisses under her breath to Cassiel. "You will be in greater danger there if the demons uncover your identity. I do not believe 'Melody' will allow you to live if she knows who you are. She is not a true ally of humanity."

"Perhaps not." Cassiel says stoically. "But I am a human at heart. Transformed into a lesser angel, yes, but still one who aligns with her people. There are going to be more humans on Sharmur than on Pixiv. I can draw upon a higher volume of faith energy and convert it into a weapon to protect them."

Beside Cassiel and Soleil, another woman slinks along, her face and body covered by a shawl.

Lily Brown, the daughter of Benjamin Brown.

"Cassiel was really brave, staying as long as she did to save people." Lily whispers. "I agree with her judgment. Humanity needs more people to stand out in these dangerous times. I believe in her."

"She is not strong enough to protect herself." Soleil argues. "We are dancing on a knife's edge. We can't risk the last living angel's life just to save some ordinary humans!"

"These 'ordinary humans' are my kin." Cassiel argues back. "I don't look at myself as an angel, anyway. I am still a human at heart. My life is no more valuable than theirs."

"But..." Soleil starts to protest.

"No more buts, Soleil. I need you to trust me and protect me from the greatest dangers. Are you still willing to do that?" Cassiel asks, looking her construct companion in the eyes.

Soleil lowers her head, looking a little glum. "Of course. We'll do it your way, then-ah!"

Soleil's eyes suddenly narrow. She grabs Cassiel and pushes the angel behind herself protectively, then looks to the great doors of the Labyrinth Core with fear and hatred in her eyes.

"It's... him!"

Cassiel's heart turns cold. She quickly peeks out from behind Soleil, her bravado from earlier disappearing in an instant.

"No... it can't be..."

The three women watch in horror as a figure slowly strolls toward the Labyrinth Core, causing the soldiers positioned outside to shriek in fright.

"G-Gressil! It's Emperor Gressil!"

"All soldiers to battle stations- wait, what's he dragging behind him? Two bodies...?"

"Oh my god! NO! Say it isn't so!!"

The soldiers lose their composure. These battle-hardened warriors scream in horror as Gressil walks right past them, unbothered by the weapons they've trained on him, and the terror on their faces.

"Haha. Hello, humans." Gressil says, his rumbling voice reeking of smugness. "It's been a while. Come, take a look. I brought presents."

The moment Gressil steps into the Core, he pauses for half a breath, then casually chucks two bodies from his right and left hands out into the central area, causing a few humans nearby to jump back in fright. When the bodies land, their eyes shrink to pinpricks.

"J-Jason Hiro? Phoebe?!"

"Dead?! Oh, divines! They're dead!!"

"Aaaaaiiieee!!"

Jason Hiro's cold corpse stares forward unblinkingly, as does his wife's. The two former leaders of humanity lay immobile on the ground, their very existence sucking all the remaining hope from anyone who looks upon them.

On the ceiling, the Demon Deities stare at the corpses in disbelief.

"Unbelievable! How could he..." Melody exclaims, her heart turning to ice.

"Why didn't he do this sooner?" Yardrat snarks. "Well, if those two are the real deal, then it looks like a lot of problems just got solved!"

"What an... interesting development." Auger adds, a cold smile playing upon his face.

Gressil swivels his head from side to side, soaking in the fear and terror of the humans around him.

"Haha. Anyone having doubts? I've been planning this for a while, you know. I waited until the Hero was busy fighting his clone. Then I killed his wife. When he came to get her, I used the emotional shock to strike him when he was most vulnerable. All that power, and the Wordsmith still fell to me. Haha."

Gressil grins evilly, looking up at the Deities with a smile that gives even them pause.

"That's right. I killed the last living Wordsmith. Now humanity has no Hope, and it doesn't have Jason either! Haha."

Many people drop to their knees. They lose their will to live, staring hollowly at the body of the Wordsmith in despair.

At this moment, Linda and Chadwick push through the crowd, having been alerted by the commotion. Despite the tragic sight before them, Linda remains stoic. She looks at Jason and Phoebe for a moment, then turns to look at Gressil.

"You don't really expect us to believe these bodies are real?"

Her words cause an ember of hope to flicker in the hearts of those present. Many people turn to look at her, then they look at Jason and Phoebe's corpses.

That's right. These remains could be fake!

But Gressil merely laughs. "Haha. You can examine them yourselves. They're the real deal. I've already accomplished my goals. Haha. Hahahaha... like I'd resort to such a petty trick. I'm sure these cadavers have some value to the Demon Deities, but they won't make a move on them. Not without my permission. Isn't that right?"

The moment the words leave Gressil's mouth, Auger flickers from the ceiling and reappears beside the Emperor of Chaos, his arms crossed. He grimaces slightly, marveling at how Gressil's chaos energy somehow manages to affect even his Middle Cosmic power. Likely, this is because his Astral Avatar only possesses strength at the Demon Emperor level.

"We will not interfere. It would be disrespectful to desecrate the bodies of humanity's honored dead. But Gressil, tsk. How rude of you to kill the Hero without the permission of your superiors. You have truly soured relations between our species!"

Gressil sneers. "Oh, I *do* beg your pardon, great Deity. Haha. I'll be expecting a punishment most severe. Make sure you think carefully on what it will be. It must be *proportional* to my crime, after all."

"Indeed. We'll discuss this matter later." Auger retorts, taking no action to punish Gressil beyond some hollow words. He vanishes from the spot and reappears on the ceiling, leaving the Emperor of Chaos alone once more.

Gressil smiles. He looks at Linda, then his gaze flicks toward a seemingly random part of the crowd.

In that moment, Cassiel's heart metaphorically freezes solid. She starts to shiver as she meets Gressil's gaze, finding herself unable to look away.

But a moment later, he averts his eyes, returning his attention to Linda.

"Terribly sorry about leaving this mess on your floor. Well, at least I found a good drop-off spot for my trash. Haha. Make sure you bury the bodies somewhere these naughty grave-robbers won't find. I'll be on my way now."

"Demon." Linda hisses. "Do you think we'll let you leave here alive?!"

She raises her fist, and all at once, a thousand guns train on Gressil's position. However, nobody shoots, as she hasn't given that order.

Gressil pauses. He cocks his head and frowns.

"Oh? You want to attack me, after I so generously returned these trinkets? I gave you the opportunity to bury the Wordsmith instead of leaving him in a hallway for Hellhounds to feast, and this is how you repay me?"

Linda's eye twitches.

Every fiber of her humanity screams to gun Gressil down, but unfortunately, logic warns her not to.

Gressil is not helpless. He is a Demon Emperor, and a powerful one at that. Even with humanity's enhanced weapons, they might not be able to take him down.

Additionally, she is all too aware that the Deities are watching. Melody alone is no match against three powerhouses at her level, and Beelzebub isn't here to help either.

Most importantly, Auger's words confirmed that he and the other Deities were extremely pleased by Gressil's actions. By eliminating the Wordsmith, Gressil completely neutered humanity's threat. They will almost certainly lose the ability to stand up to the demons as time drags on.

Attacking Gressil could spark a flame that would swallow all the humans still present in the Core. Countless precious civilians would die, lowering humanity's numbers even further!

Linda's eyes flicker with rage. Losing Neil, then Hope, then Jason, and even Phoebe, as well as hundreds of thousands of other humans has her experiencing levels of rage she never could have fathomed a week before. But now, those emotions threaten to jeopardize everything humanity has left!

Just as Linda is about to give up and tell her soldiers to lower their weapons, a voice rings out from the crowd.

"You! You fucking BASTARD!!"

A demoness pounces from behind the wall of humans, her eyes feral with rage. She snaps a long, stretchy arm at Gressil's neck, aiming to decapitate him as her fingers turn to knives.

Gressil instantly teleports to the side, dodging the attack. He looks at Belial, his smile vanishing as he senses her volcanic hatred erupting into the heavens.

Of all the Emperors in the Labyrinth, she is, without a doubt, the one who poses the greatest threat to him.

After all... she nearly killed him the last time they fought!

Belial's knives stab into the ground. She yanks herself forward, then alters course by relying on her strength to continue striking at Gressil's new position. He quickly teleports away, and she hits the floor running, immediately locking onto his second position. With so many humans taking up space, Gressil can't maneuver freely even in such a wide-open area as the Labyrinth Core.

"Ahhh!!"

Belial roars. Her arms swiftly start to morph and stretch, snapping at Gressil faster than any human's eyes can react.

Gressil teleports once, twice, three times. He flickers around rapidly, narrowly evading death as Belial's highly attuned demonic vision easily tracks him by the void left wherever his body teleports. Instead of sensing his demonic energy, she senses the point where all the mana in the room is at its lowest, and uses that to quickly lock-on to his spatial coordinates.

She pursues him relentlessly, forcing him to escape back into the Labyrinth.

"Come back here, you dead dog!" Belial screams. "Is that all you can do, RUN?! You took her from me! YOU TOOK HER!!"

Some of the human troopers look on, wanting to at least shoot at Gressil to try and assist Belial, but without Linda's express approval, they don't dare.

Linda watches as Belial and Gressil disappear further into the Labyrinth, eventually disappearing from sight. The Labyrinth quakes and rumbles each time Belial's fists smash its walls, making the humans and monsters still in the Core shudder at the thought of the fates they'd meet if she came after them.

Eventually, Linda lowers her fist, causing the troopers to lower their guns, and she gestures toward Jason and Phoebe's bodies.

"Recover those two." Linda says, her tone empty. "We'll verify their identities and determine what to do next based on whether those bodies are really... *them*."

The humans fall silent, watching as four troopers each hoist up Jason's body, then four more retrieve Phoebe. The moment of silence extends outward as people lower their heads, respectfully acknowledging the passing of their Hero and his wife.

Jason was humanity's muscle. Phoebe was its heart.

With the two of them gone, many people can't help but fall into despondency.

How can they possibly continue, knowing that they no longer have a Hero on their side?

Linda, seeing the pain on everyone's faces, comes to a swift decision.

She takes a step forward and raises her voice.

"Brothers. Sisters! I know this is hard for all of you to accept. It pains me to say this... but both Wordsmiths are likely dead. Phoebe Hiro joins them. And Neil Adams, my husband, and our great Commander... he is also dead!"

She remains silent for a moment, swallowing heavily before continuing to speak.

"But do not give in to despair! Have you forgotten?! We still have Heroes! Hope raised a fine family! His sons and daughter will carry on their father's work! No doubt, they will need time to grieve, and it is a fact that their powers are not as versatile as those of the

Wordsmiths. But a Hero is a goddamn Hero! Many Heroes have existed, and all of them have left an impact on our species!"

Linda closes her eyes and pounds her fist against her chest, beating it in grief.

"Even if all our Heroes die, it does not matter. Do you hear me?! IT DOES NOT MATTER!! Because we are humans! We improvise! We adapt! We overcome! Even when the odds are stacked against us, we resist those who think themselves our superiors!"

Acting on pure instinct, Linda raises a finger to point at the Deities on the ceiling above.

"Do you hear me, you villains?! You may think you've won the war, but we STILL have Champions! And if you kill them, we'll just raise more! We will never give up! Because we are humans! And humanity ALWAYS rises to fight its greatest threats! Unless you exterminate us entirely, you will never go to sleep thinking it will be smooth sailing for your evil, disgusting, demonic machinations!"

Linda's words lift the spirits of the humans listening. Countless soldiers record her speech from a myriad of angles and broadcast those words to the soldiers in the back, who in turn broadcast it to the platoons that migrated to Pixiv and Sharmur. They, likewise, broadcast her words to the rest of the people on humanity's new makeshift homeworlds.

"So go ahead!" Linda says, her face contorting into a jeering expression. "Laugh at us! Mock us! Revel in our pain! But someday soon, you will eat shit when we spray it in your faces! Humanity will not be bullied by any of your ilk! We will have the last laugh, no matter how long it takes or how many lives we lose in the process! And someday... someday we will conquer this entire galaxy! When that day comes, you'll wish you had stood beside us from the beginning!"

Her words evoke a chorus of cheers. The humans inside the Core raise their fists to the sky, then extend their middle fingers toward the Deities above them.

"Screw you, demon bastards!"

"Humanity will reign supreme!"

"We're not afraid of a bunch of bullies!"

"Humans never give up!!"

As the humans chat various slogans, Melody's heart sinks.

Linda, you idiot! If the Deities choose to attack, they'll massacre you all! I can't protect you by myself!

But to her surprise, Auger and the others remain mute. They simply cross their arms and look down on the humans, unbothered by their protest.

"Hmm. I pray that made them feel a little better." Yardrat says. "But what a shame. I've looked at the remaining Heroes and found them lacking. A bunch of brats consisting of a musclehead, a fancy magical-girl, and a boy barely out of diapers. They're no threat to us."

"We only need to worry about *two* people." Kristoff says, directing a smug smile at Melody. Naturally, the other entity he is thinking of can be none other than Beelzebub.

"It was a fine speech." Auger says, surprising the others by praising Linda. "Who knows? It may even have some positive, if otherwise minor effects. Now, Melody, if you'd be so kind, I tire of these insects taking up valuable space in *my* Core. Tell them to scurry off to their safe-worlds."

Melody grimaces. Luckily, the other Deities didn't lash out, or the humans would truly be in for a world of hurt.

"Yeah. Sure. I'll do that." Melody says, disappearing from the ceiling and reappearing in the crowd below.

Auger strokes his goatee thoughtfully after she departs.

I do wonder if Hope's children will ever pose us a threat, though. Perhaps we should try finding their location, just in case a... preliminary strike... would best suit demonkind's interests.

* * *

Meanwhile, Belial chases Gressil at top speed. She tears down the Labyrinth halls, sticking to him like a fly on a turd. Even when Gressil teleports hundreds of feet away and reappears inside a tunnel disconnected from the one Belial is in, she merely smashes through the Labyrinth's ultra-hard walls like a brute, reaching Gressil's new position within seconds.

"How troublesome!" Gressil growls.

Belial pounces at him, but this time, when he teleports, he changes his strategy and reappears within arm's length of Belial, taking her by surprise.

THUMP!!!

Gressil smashes his fist against Belial's face, pounding her into the side of the Labyrinth walls. While he might not be as strong as her, he is absolutely a powerhouse among the Emperors, and he manages to put her lights out for a second or two.

Instead of continuing his successful attack in the hopes of killing her, Gressil takes the chance to put some serious distance between himself and Belial. He teleports away and withdraws his Chaos Aura within himself, making his presence much smaller. Then he turns invisible, hiding within his illusions while sending out fake versions of himself to travel down multiple hallways. By the time Belial recovers from her momentary stun, she has already failed to lock-on to Gressil's new position.

"No! NO! You coward!!" Belial yells. "Come back here! Face me like a man!!"

But Gressil does not oblige. He fades away, and before long, Belial loses track of him entirely.

A minute later, her rage deflates, turning to despair. She heals her wounded face, then slumps against the wall of the pitch-black hallway, her heart turning to stone.

"Phoebe... Phoebe... I... I'm so sorry... I failed you. I should have been there for you."

It wasn't long ago that Fiona recalled Belial to Chrona. There, she learned that Phoebe had died during teleportation, likely perishing due to the sudden increase in time dilation speed. But hearing Gressil speak, Belial thought at the time he must have somehow been the one to kill her instead!

It's only now, after her rage has cooled, that Belial realizes the truth of the matter.

"No... it wasn't Gressil." Belial whispers, her eyes flickering with insight. "Phoebe *did* die during teleportation. That scheming... he didn't kill Phoebe. He lied to everyone in the Core... but to what end? If he didn't kill Phoebe, then does that mean he didn't kill Jason, either? But... Jason is dead! Does it even matter if Gressil killed him or not?"

Belial grabs at her hair in frustration. Unable to think clearly, all she can feel is grief swallowing her soul from all directions.

Phoebe was everything to her.

She loved Phoebe. She loved her as much as she loved Satan, all those years ago.

She would have killed for Phoebe. She would have died for her.

But now Phoebe is gone.

"I... I don't have anything left to live for." Belial mutters.

She lays there, in the hallway, her back slumped against the wall.

Minutes pass. Belial stares ahead, her expression vacant, tears slowly trickling down her face.

But eventually, Belial regains her composure. She staggers to her feet and wipes her tear-filled eyes.

"Phoebe loved humanity. If... if she's gone... then I'll love humanity too."

"And... there's still Timothy. I can't let him grow up motherless. I'll take care of him. I'll do what I can to raise him right. That's what Phoebe would have wanted."

Belial looks up at the ceiling.

"That's the least I can do to honor her memory...!"

Part 614: Bubble Worlds

Beelzebub flies around inside the massive void comprising the Cube's internal world. Having lost his Cosmic power, he is unable to traverse stellar distances efficiently, but the Phoenix conjures a miniature incarnation to attach to his back and speed up his travels. Additionally, the inside of the Cube is oxygen-rich even outside the bubble-worlds made by Jason Hiro, so Beelzebub has no trouble breathing.

The Overlord of Fission speeds from bubble world to bubble world, chatting with the Phoenix all the while.

"So each bubble world has a different 'focus'?" Beelzebub asks.

[They do.] The Phoenix answers. [Jason wants to ensure that there are a large variety of pleasant biomes, but also harsh ones for people who enjoy that sort of thing. Also, since these bubble worlds were originally intended to be used for military training, there are 'Deathworlds' designed for maximum danger. It is more than possible for humans who enter to die due to freezing cold, scorching heat, deadly insects, and other hostile creatures. They are only intended for short-term military training, and thus there are not too many of them.]

"We have 100,000 humans inside the Cube." Beelzebub says. "How much room do we have for further population increases? Are they going to run out of space?"

[They would have.] The Phoenix replies. [But that was before my Ascension. Now, the Cube is no longer in danger of running out of energy. My Cosmic Reserves are more than enough to build additional worlds capable of housing a billion humans or more. That is *also* before we factor in the modifications Jason Hiro has made for the humans themselves to supply power to the Cube.]

"What sorts of modifications?"

[Jason adjusted the Cube so Faith Energy could empower it. He originally intended for the humans across the cosmos to power the Cube from anywhere they reside, but those inside the Cube are the most energy-efficient, since interstellar distances decrease Faith's yield.]

The Phoenix continues. [Thus, the humans here will empower the Cube in a near-infinite positive cycle. The more humans there are, the more Faith Energy they will provide, thus granting me the power to expand the Cube's bubble worlds and house more of them. At that point, in the unknown future, we will have to worry more about the Cube's physical space limitations. I estimate that if I were to efficiently maximize all the available space, the Cube could easily house one or more trillions of humans at once.]

"Trillions..." Beelzebub muttered. "The Cube in many ways reminds me of the Labyrinth."

[Tell me more about this 'Labyrinth.'] The Phoenix requests.

"The Labyrinth houses the vast majority of demons that currently exist." Beelzebub obliges. "I don't know how many of my people there are, but there are certainly trillions of them, plus many more living on various worlds across the Milky Way. Hell slowly expands over time based on how many demons are inside, as well as monsters and other life forms. Traveling from one corner to another is an arduous journey even for a Demon Emperor. Most low-level demons and monsters stay within their own zones or shuttle around using the power of Warper demons."

[Most intriguing. Much has changed since my consciousness was last fully aware of the happenings inside the Milky Way.] The Phoenix says, accepting his explanation without prejudice. [There is still so much for me to learn. Tell me, what of the angels? Do any still remain among the living?]

Beelzebub continues to fly toward the nearest bubble-world, but his movement slows a little at this question.

"I'm afraid not. During the Kolvaxian invasion on Maiura, Archangel Uriel was the last of her species still among the living. The Plague took her, along with the souls of her brothers. Now, there are no angels left in the galaxy. They're... extinct."

[Including my Creator, Camael?] The Phoenix asks.

"I don't know when Camael died, but I believe it was at some point during the Energy Wars, 100,000 years ago." Beelzebub answers. "I'm sorry."

The Phoenix seems to mentally shrug. [I am a creature of rebirth. The end of life is a normal part of existence. Tell me more about these 'Kolvaxians'. What manner of creatures are they?]

"I don't know a lot about them. Nobody does." Beelzebub replies. "They're alien life forms. Faceless abominations. They appeared about 90,000 years ago, some time after the end of the Energy Wars. They can travel underground quickly, and often appear on planets as singular entities before grabbing other living creatures, pulling them underground, then returning with those creatures having been turned into Kolvaxians. They swallow and devour other life-forms, assimilating them into their ranks. And right now, they're winning the war for the Milky Way."

[Hmm... and you say they are considered a Plague?] The Phoenix asks.

"That's how the Volgrim refer to them." Beelzebub affirms with a nod of his head. "The Kolvaxians are a plague that devours worlds, turning them into Hives filled with millions or even billions more Plaguehosts. Recently, they devoured the body of one of Jason's creations, an entity named after King Arthur, called Artoria. When they did that, their bodies became extremely powerful. Every individual Plaguehost now possesses a body as durable as a Middle Cosmic."

[Best Friend, would you mind sharing your mental images of these Kolvaxians with me?] The Phoenix requests politely.

"I can *do* that?" Beelzebub asks.

[Naturally. We are still connected on a spiritual level, after all.]

"Oh. Well, I'd be happy to. How should we go about it?"

After following some instructions on how to alter his psyche, Beelzebub transmits a large amount of mental imagery to the Phoenix, and she falls silent for a short time.

[...This 'Plague' is fascinating.] The Phoenix eventually says. [And terrifying. What an impressive species. Extremely formidable, able to adapt the bodies of assimilated hosts into empowerments for the species as a whole. I daresay they are nearly a perfect life-form.]

Beelzebub sneers. "Perfect? They have no free will. All things absorbed by the Plague become mindless monsters. They're human-shaped ants."

[Perhaps. But that does not make their biology any less impressive.] The Phoenix says. [Ah, we have nearly reached the first bubble world.]

She gestures with her wing toward a bright-blue 'planet' smaller than Earth's moon, Luna. Beelzebub raises an eyebrow when he observes just how tiny the little world is.

He adjusts course, and within a minute, he arrives near its upper atmosphere. It barely takes him seconds to drop through the thick cloud cover and land on the ground below.

He finds himself on a coastline where waves artificially splash against the shore, despite the fact that this false planet has no moon to cause such tides. When Beelzebub looks up, he realizes that the sky above him is completely false. He cannot see the Cube's inner world at all, only a magical mirage that hides the true nature of reality outside this bubble world.

Sensing his thoughts, the Phoenix explains. [Jason wants these worlds to feel as real as Earth itself. Thus, each planet has multiple enchantments placed upon them to simulate all the expected features of planets with nearby stars, moons, and other such things. This particular world is known as Antiqua, and is a water-world with only 40% of its space available to settle on. Its oceans are deeper than you might expect, extending a few thousand meters downward, with a rich variety of life-forms living in the aquatic depths. It is ideal for sea-loving humans to settle upon.]

When Beelzebub looks elsewhere in the sky, he spots a false sun shining down, informing him that the world even has a simulated day and night system in place.

"Jason really thought of everything, huh?"

[Not quite. I have noticed multiple minor issues, but I will work out those problems over time.] The Phoenix says.

Beelzebub starts walking toward the shoreline, where multiple trees sit with delicious-looking fruits hanging down from low-hanging branches. These trees have small but sharp spikes sticking out of their trunks, making climbing them an act of suicide. Anyone who tries will likely have their hands shredded and will bleed out and die before long.

"Say, Phoenix? It just occurred to me." Beelzebub says, as he walks into the forest, taking care not to cut himself on the spike-trees. "You're a Middle Cosmic now. Does that mean you can fight in my stead?"

[Unfortunately, I cannot, Best Friend.] The Phoenix replies. [My existence is presently tied to the Cube. I am unable to travel far without rapidly losing my energy. Additionally, I am not a combat-focused artifact. I excel at rebirth and flame manipulation of the 'life' type. I can create things easily, but destruction is outside my purview.]

"Then why was I, under your power, so strong?" Beelzebub presses further.

[Because you are a different sort of flame manipulator.] The Phoenix explains. [You are destructive and violent. In a hostile universe, this is not a bad thing. It means you are able to do things with your Cosmic power that I cannot.]

Beelzebub pauses his walking to tap his lower lip. "Could you infuse your power into me to empower me back to a Cosmic level? You know, in case the Volgrim return?"

[I could, but I would revert to my embarrassing, weaker self.] The Phoenix replies. [It would also adversely affect the Cube's operations. My lesser self was unable to properly manage the constructs within the Cube. If need be, I would prefer to use the Sentry Stars as our primary defensive weapons in the event of an enemy incursion.]

She pauses.

[You have nothing to worry about, Best Friend. In time, I have full faith you will regain your Cosmic power. This Cube is not weak at all. It was constructed by Archangel Camael near the peak of her ancient power, in absolute secrecy. Even Archangel Raphael was unaware of its existence. It is extremely sturdy and can easily resist the attacks of Middle and High Cosmics. Only Apex Cosmics pose it a real threat once I seal its entrance. Even they would need time to burrow inside and slaughter the humans within.]

"So there's no threat of a Plague incursion?" Beelzebub asks.

[Not unless someone grants a Plaguehost entry.] The Phoenix answers. [I pray nobody would be that foolish.]

Beelzebub nods. He continues walking, and before long, the tree cover parts to reveal several wooden houses with straw roofs built to insulate against the midday heat. Naturally, Antiqua is a planet controlled by the Phoenix and designed to be extremely moderate. It never faces extreme weather changes, hurricanes, or other such things, so raising families is quite easy here.

Beelzebub steps into the village and pauses to watch from afar. A group of children play in the dirt road some distance away, perhaps ten of them. The village itself appears rather primitive, but Beelzebub spots many signs of modern humanity lingering around the edges, such as the digital devices carried by some of the men and women walking around. Most importantly, Beelzebub notices additional signs of a recent surge of human population, due to the Phoenix rapidly teleporting humans from Tarus II to the various bubble worlds in a haste. Some of the houses appear brand new, and many are still being built at that very moment. Beelzebub also observes carpenters and architects hurriedly

whipping up new homes for the unexpected migrants. Based on information from the Phoenix, this world only has a population of a thousand or so humans.

While the children play, the parents look extremely grim. They do not appear happy, and that is likely because they know at least some of the events that have played out in realspace.

Suddenly, one of the children cries out in alarm. Beelzebub turns to see a little girl pointing at him, her eyes wide with surprise. Not quite fear, but uncertainty, as she catches sight of the red-skinned visitor.

Seeing her reaction, several of the adults nearby turn to look at Beelzebub. They frown, then relax once they identify him.

"Beelzebub!" A man says, hurrying over. "You were teleported here too? What's the situation on Tarus II? Have you heard anything?"

Beelzebub looks at the man, but doesn't recognize him. This isn't surprising, since Beelzebub's face is extremely well known, while he comparatively knows almost none of the humans.

"You haven't heard?" Beelzebub asks, frowning slightly.

"Nothing. Nothing at all." The man says, his voice anxious. "When I was teleported, I expected to see my wife and son, but they never arrived. I'm going crazy waiting for news!"

Beelzebub's frown deepens. He looks around, observing several other men and women looking at him, waiting for answers.

[I have not told anyone that Tarus II was destroyed.] The Phoenix says, secretly transmitting her thoughts only to Beelzebub. [My lesser self lacked awareness of what happened, and now that I've ascended, I determined it would not be appropriate for me to do so. You are a better-known face with more credibility among these mortals. You should be the one to deliver the news.]

Beelzebub's frown grows even uglier upon hearing the Phoenix's words, but he doesn't address them out loud.

Still, his expression, and the long pause before replying causes many people's hearts to tighten.

"I'm... sorry." Beelzebub says slowly. "I don't know what happened to your wife and son. But I do know... Tarus II is gone. The Volgrim destroyed it."

"What? No! NO!" The man exclaims, his pupils shrinking to pinpricks. The strength leaves his legs, and he sags to his knees while grabbing onto Beelzebub's shirt. "Please, say it isn't so! Is my family dead? Did they get transferred somewhere else?! The portal network is down! We've lost contact with the other Realms!"

Beelzebub looks around in confusion. "Portal Network? Realms?"

"You must have just arrived." Another man says, his expression not quite as anxious as the first. "I am the leader of this village. Come with me."

Beelzebub follows him, and before long the small gathering of humans leads Beelzebub to a pylon with a magical blue crystal in its center sitting in the middle of the village.

"This device connects different Realms together." The village leader explains. "Last I heard, there were several hundred. By activating its magical matrices, we can walk between Realms to visit our fellow humans. Unfortunately, our Portal Node stopped functioning. Nobody here knows how to repair it."

Beelzebub nods. He walks over to it, and the Phoenix communicates with him in secret.

[To prevent the spread of panic, I temporarily disabled all the Portal Nodes. I can enable them again, if you'd like.]

Beelzebub nods, and the Phoenix proceeds to tap into the Portal Node, reactivating it once more.

"A-amazing! Emperor Beelzebub, you are truly impressive!" The village leader says, upon seeing the pylon activate.

"Please wait some time before traveling around." Beelzebub says. "I need to inform the rest of the humans about what has happened. Focus on building your village. Expect the newest arrivals to become... permanent."

The village leader's eyes lose some of their luster. He nods dimly and watches as Beelzebub summons a portal to a different bubble world, then passes through, allowing the portal to close behind him.

On this new world, a desert planet with multiple oases around, Beelzebub informs the people there of Tarus II's demise. Then, he travels to another world, and another, and another.

He becomes faster and more efficient, especially after learning that many Realms have members of Jepthath's Legion on them, and those members have already spread news of Tarus II's fall. He starts intentionally targeting worlds that no Legionnaires have been to, which saves him even more time.

When he arrives on one ordinary-looking world, a familiar face rushes over to meet him.

"Beelzebub! It's you!"

Beelzebub smiles. "Emperor Kiari. Are you well? I didn't expect to see you here."

"I'm not well!" Kiari exclaims, wringing her hands together. "Saul! Have you seen Saul? I can't find him, and it's been hours since I arrived here!"

"Saul..." Beelzebub says, his expression darkening. "Jason designated multiple high-value targets for extraction. You were one of them. Saul wasn't?"

"I... I don't know..." Kiari whispers, her face fraught with anxiety. "He was only an ordinary human... b-but he was Solomon's nephew! That has to count for something! Maybe Hope's Hall of Heroes picked him up?"

"Yeah. Maybe." Beelzebub says, glancing around. "Phoenix, can you find Saul on any of the bubble worlds?"

The Phoenix responds, this time projecting her words to Beelzebub and Kiari both.

[I am not familiar with this 'Saul'. If he is a mundane human, he will not have a mana signature I can trace. Let me analyze your memory of him, Beelzebub. I will see if I can locate him based on males of similar builds and appearances.]

Beelzebub nods. He transmits several memories of Saul to the ancient bird, and she in turn scans all the different worlds to look for the missing man.

Kiari glances at the miniature flaming bird attached to Beelzebub's back. "And she is...?"

"The Phoenix. She controls the bubble worlds." Beelzebub explains. "She's extremely powerful. She'll definitely find Saul if he's here."

"If he's here..." Kiari mumbles, trying not to act overly anxious.

Minutes later, the Phoenix speaks up. [I have identified twenty-four human males of similar builds and skin colors. Forgive me, but these mortals all look alike. Perhaps one of them is this 'Saul' you are looking for.]

She summons a phantasmal image of a man standing half a head taller than Kiari. The Emperor of Pestilence shakes her head. "No... not him."

Then, the Phoenix summons a different man. "Not him either."

"No, not him..."

"Close, but not quite."

"No."

"No..."

Kiari's voice starts to tremble. By the twentieth failure, her body also starts shaking.

Once all twenty-four men have come up negative, the Phoenix sighs.

[I was unable to identify any further males matching the description you gave me. I apologize. He is not inside the bubble worlds.]

"No!" Kiari cries, nearly fainting. "He can't be dead... can't be..."

"Don't give up just yet!" Beelzebub exclaims, quickly squeezing her shoulder as she sags against him. "There's still the Hall of Heroes, and also Chrona. Saul might be there. I refuse to believe Solomon would allow his nephew to die. Even if Hope died, Solomon would make sure to save Saul."

Kiari nods numbly, her movements lacking energy. Beelzebub helps her stand, and she touches her barely-visible pregnant belly.

"Beelzebub... you have to find him... he's my everything..."

"I will. Saul is a good friend." Beelzebub promises. "You just need to remain strong and keep hopeful. It won't do the baby any good for you to fall into a depression- and besides! He could also be in the Labyrinth! We have lots of places to search. So, chin up, woman!"

That seems to do the trick. Kiari regains some of her strength and pulls away from Beelzebub, smiling weakly at him.

"Th-thank you for... taking care of me. I'm sorry I'm so useless."

"Useless? Hardly. You did more positive things for humanity than I ever have." Beelzebub says, waving off her words. "Say, why don't you come along with me to the other bubble worlds? As soon as I can contact the other dimension hubs, I'll give you the good news."

"Okay. Thank you. I'd like that." Kiari says, her face brightening up a little bit.

Meanwhile, Beelzebub resumes his mission; to seek out all the different Cube Realms and inform the remnant humans of the fate that has befallen their species.

Only time will tell if his mission bears fruit...

Part 615: Entering Sharmur

Inside the Labyrinth Core, the number of humans has dwindled significantly. Already, of the tens of thousands who were huddled inside immediately following the destruction of Tarus II, less than half remain. The others have already filed through one of the two Warpgates leading to Pixiv and Sharmur.

Demon Barons and Dukes stand inside the Core on the peripheries, their expressions solemn, as they watch the humans filing outside. As subordinates of the Deities, these demons might love to hurt the humans, but they cannot. They know well that humanity has at least one Demon Deity on their side, as well as a few Emperors. Belial herself sent Gressil scurrying away in a panic not half an hour earlier, and the humans still have Kiari and Leeroy on their side, to say nothing of Beelzebub.

The Demon Deities have not held back. Already, rumors of Beelzebub's frightening ascension and massive power spike have begun to spread.

Demon Emperor Crow watches from behind the Sharmur Warpgate, her expression ugly, as a pair of Barons behind her whisper conspiratorially.

"For reals! I heard he smashed apart ten planets and sent the Volgrim packing."

"Beelzebub? I mean he's strong, but there's no way he became a Deity. That's crazy talk."

"I thought so too! Only Diablo could turn Emperors into Deities, right? And he's dead now. But no, this comes down from the top. Beelzy broke through the power barrier all on his own."

"Man, since when did it become so easy to break through? I heard the Emperors spent 100,000 years trying and they only ever failed. Then Wolfram made it, died, and now every Joe Blow is becoming a Deity!"

Crow's irritation finally boils over. She snaps her head to the side and shouts at her two subordinates. "Caw!! Both of you, shut it! I don't want to hear another word about that blasted Beelzebub!"

The two Barons lower their heads, looking contrite. "Y-yes, Emperor Crow."

Dissatisfied, Crow returns her gaze forward, grumbling to herself under her breath.

"How did he do it?" Crow mutters. "Damned Beelzebub. Ascending like it's a measly party trick. I sit here, conduct rituals like a damned clown, and he gets blown to smithereens only to come back stronger than before. Outrageous. There's no karma in the universe."

Crow's gaze flicks around the crowd. Suddenly, out of the corner of her eye, she spots a pair of human women. She looks at them for a moment, feeling something might be slightly off about them. That feeling passes, and her eyes move on.

Meanwhile, inside the crowd, one of those human women feels a chill go down her spine. The feeling of a powerful pair of eyes falling on her makes her blood turn to ice, but then the gaze vanishes, and she breathes a little easier.

"Is something wrong, Cammy?" Her companion asks. "Your heartrate has spiked noticeably. Are you experiencing a panic attack due to the presence of so many people?"

"No, Serra. It's nothing like that." Cassiel says, tightly clutching the Heaven's Shroud hidden under her white dress. "I... I felt that a powerful entity was looking at me. An enemy."

Soleil quickly looks around the crowd of tens of thousands of people, but she doesn't notice anyone unusual. "Emperor Belial scared Gressil away. It is unlikely to be him, though I am still keeping my eyes peeled."

"It wasn't him." Cassiel says quietly. "I don't know who it was. But the gaze felt... familiar."

Soleil stands a little closer to Cassiel and wraps her arm around her protectively. The two continue to wait as the crowd slowly shuffles forward, with people entering one of the two Warpgates leading to Pixiv or Sharmur.

Eventually, a small commotion rises up behind the rear of the crowd. Cassiel turns around to see Emperor Belial returning through the Core entrance, looking a little depressed but also entirely uninjured.

"Seems she drove Gressil away." Cassiel mutters.

"Based on her solemn expression, she failed to kill him." Soleil replies. "Unfortunate, to say the least. As long as he's around, you'll always be in danger."

"Why did Belial attack him, anyway?" Cassiel asks.

Soleil's eyes shine for a moment as she rapidly calculates the various possibilities.

"Based upon information I've collected since my creation, there is a 54.3% chance that Gressil's statements about killing the Wordsmith and his wife incited Emperor Belial into a rage. She was publicly seen many times alongside them, and appeared to have close relations with both. It is likely she was a close friend of Phoebe Hiro in particular."

"So she was angry about losing someone she loved." Cassiel says, nodding slightly. "She was able to drive Gressil away. Is Belial... strong?"

"You do not know of her strength?" Soleil retorts.

"I... know she's a shapeshifter." Cassiel says. "And she fought during Stormbringer. But aside from some information Raphael told me long ago, I'm not clear on her limits."

"Physically speaking, Belial is publicly acknowledged to be the strongest of all Emperors." Soleil explains. "She was more than capable of putting down Bael at his peak, and even Emperor Crow was unable to match her strength. Crow possesses superior defenses as a result of her armored feathers, but Belial's 'True Succubus Form' rivals them in equal measure. In a match of pure strength, it is said that Belial wins every time."

"But when we met her at the hospital, Belial said she lost to Emperor Ose." Cassiel points out. "If she's so strong, then...?"

"Strength alone does not dictate victory." Soleil points out. "There are many such cases throughout history. The angels never should have lost to the demons, but a combination of arrogance and naïveté regarding the demons' capabilities led to their slow erosion of power and ultimate defeat. Ose was a bad matchup for Belial."

A minute passes. Cassiel remains quiet, thinking to herself about a great many things.

Then, she turns and starts to pull away from the crowd, making Soleil raise an eyebrow.

"My lady? Is something wrong?"

"No. Not exactly." Cassiel says. "It is simply... I have avoided demons like Belial for a long time. But looking at her past history, she seems to have changed greatly over the last six years, and likely the 100,000 before then. I think... she could prove a valuable ally."

"She is a demon." Soleil says simply.

"She is humanity's friend. She has proven her loyalty time and time again." Cassiel counters. "Come along."

Despite her misgivings, Soleil simply nods. She follows along as Cassiel makes her way to the back of the crowd. There, Belial stands, surrounded by ordinary humans and even a random Demon Baron on humanity's side. Cassiel hesitates when she sees the Baron, but only pauses for an instant before gently gliding through the throng of people toward Belial.

"Um... excuse me. Excuse me." Cassiel says quietly, as she draws within earshot and reaches toward Belial.

Belial, seemingly in a daze, snaps out of it and glances around, meeting Cassiel's eyes. "Huh? What is it? Oh... you?"

Despite having met Cassiel and Soleil at the hospital some months before, Belial only recognizes them when Cassiel subtly reveals her Heaven's Shroud by pulling it from her blouse for a moment before quickly tucking it back inside. Belial's eyes flicker with realization.

"Sorry, it's just, I was wondering if we could speak, Lady Belial." Cassiel says softly.

"Call me Samantha." Belial says, smiling faintly. Her smile disappears, and she carefully glances upward toward the ceiling, where the astral projections of the Demon Deities stand, upside-down. "I was... about to head to Sharmur. Would you like to join me there?"

"It'll be a while before the crowd is finished transferring." Cassiel points out.

"I never worry about crowds." Belial says confidently.

She touches Cassiel's arm, nods at Soleil, and then starts weaving her way through the bunched-up humans. Cassiel and Soleil follow her, and within a few minutes, they pass through the gate to Sharmur.

Arriving on a new world is always a shocking experience. When Cassiel and Soleil pass through, they arrive on an Earth-like planet that is superficially similar to humanity's homeworld, yet distinctly different from it in countless ways.

The first thing Cassiel notices is the smell. A musky, wet, tropical odor permeates the air, making her forehead crease as she tries to identify the alien smells barraging her nostrils. Strange bugs the size of dragonflies buzz around in the air a hundred feet above the ground, driven back by a faint but distinct high-pitched noise produced by various magical devices, designed for humans and demons to be able to ignore for the most part.

Naturally, demons, with their more sensitive hearing, will be more irritated by these noises than the comparatively simpler humans, but compared to allowing these giant bugs to pester them, the tradeoff is worth it.

What surprises Cassiel the most are the three giant moons visible in the sky above Sharmur. Unlike Earth, which only had one, Sharmur is quite stereotypical for paradise-class worlds in the Milky Way, as its number of moons strongly correlate to the average number most have, at four. These moons are not lifeless either. One of them appears to be colored green and blue, another hotspot of life, habitable by Sentients, though currently populated only by ordinary creatures and game.

Cassiel looks around in a daze, finding herself standing atop a tall temple, rising nearly twenty stories aboveground. Shaped like a pyramid with its top cut off, this temple is Sharmur's Warpgate Nexus, a place built by the Volgrim hundreds of thousands, if not millions of years ago. Four statues of ancient Volgrim Ascended stand at the corners of the Nexus, each one holding their palms out while facing the north, east, west, and south. Their presence seems to state that the Volgrim forbid unauthorized creatures from coming, though whether that had any effect on the Kolvaxians when they attacked a year earlier seems unlikely.

"Over here." Belial says, gesturing to Cassiel. "Come with me."

Cassiel hesitates, momentarily fearing this is a ploy to trap her and Soleil in an isolated area so Belial can kill them. But a moment of thought reassures her that this concept makes no sense for the Belial who has been with humanity for the past six years, so she simply nods and follows along.

The demon, angel, and black hole construct arrive at the edge of the pyramid, where a long staircase awaits, leading twenty stories straight down to the ground. Various statues of famous living and dead demons line the walkway, along with handrails so people can more easily ascend and descend without losing their footing.

"Where are you taking us?" Cassiel asks.

"Somewhere safe." Belial says, a hint of warning in her voice. "Beware. The shadows have ears."

Cassiel nods. She and Soleil follow after Belial, and thirty minutes later, they arrive in a ruined city that has already begun reconstruction. Formerly the capital city of Sharmur, known as Murax, this city was devastated by the Kolvaxian attack, and many of its famed

buildings and sights crumbled to rubble. Cassiel's expression dims visibly as she and Soleil walk past countless humans wearing rags, uniforms, and whatever else they can scrounge up, all working to slowly clear away the rubble.

"Before I joined the Wordsmith and his fellow humans, I often visited Sharmur." Belial says, as they walk. "I've always liked this world. The Hell of Isolation treated humans well. Not like slaves, but like trusted subordinates, or perhaps beloved pets. They could never entirely be equals due to their power differences and the restrictions placed by the 'Overlords', but Shax and Murmur sought to lead a world where all could be treated well, regardless of their species."

Cassiel looks at Belial's back as the Demon Emperor leads her toward an unknown destination. "You were Satan the Devil's wife. Why do you care so much about humanity?"

"I have a different perspective from my fellow demons." Belial says, after thinking for a moment. She doesn't look back at Cassiel as she speaks. "They see humans as cattle. Food to empower themselves. But I was a Demon Emperor from the moment my people met the ancient dragon. I never felt the hunger for power that the lesser demons did. Perhaps that gave me a chance to look at the relationship between humans and demons from a more detached perspective. I found the cruelty and violence to be... repugnant."

Belial pauses. She spots a small hut, relatively intact, and currently abandoned. She inspects it for a moment, then steps inside. Cassiel and Soleil follow her.

It doesn't take a genius to realize that humans once lived in this small clay-built abode. At only ten feet high and a hundred feet of square internal space, it's barely big enough for one or two people, made evident by the single bed covered in dust tucked in the corner. A small wood-fed stove in the back, a table, and some chairs are all that remains as proof humans once lived here. No longer among the living, devoured by the Plague, not even pictures remain of the hut's former residents.

Belial dusts off a chair and sits at the table, heavily plunking down in it while exhaling softly. Cassiel sits across from her, while Soleil remains standing, due to there only being two chairs. She doesn't mind, as she never feels fatigued anyway.

"So you grew to care for humans?" Cassiel asks.

"Satan and I had a complicated relationship." Belial says evenly. "I loved him. He loved me. But... I did not share his hatred of the angels, the humans, or the Titans. Many

times, in order to cause mayhem, he would send me into human palaces, disguised as a dancer, a handmaiden, or even a... personal servant... for the male rulers. I bewitched them, led them into traps, and Satan killed them. He toppled countless governments and kingdoms this way over humanity's long history, and was rarely found out."

"You killed those men?" Cassiel asks.

"No. Like I said, I led them into traps. It was always Satan or one of his lackeys who did the killing."

Belial pauses, then shakes her head.

"Actually. I *did* kill them. Indirectly, but I was their executioner. I always tried to excuse my actions by deflecting blame, but the truth was, I took the easy way out for my conscience by letting others do the dirty work. If I hadn't set up those men, they would have died of old age."

"Perhaps." Soleil retorts. "Or they could have been assassinated through other means. One cannot assume they would die of old age simply because you did not kill them. Powerful people always have many enemies."

"Mere platitudes." Belial says resting her cheek on her palm. She places an elbow on the table and absentmindedly starts drawing circles in the dust. "My point is that I'm a demon. I've killed people, even if not with my own hands. I'm just trying to make up for it now."

"So you want to be a better person, then?" Cassiel asks pointedly.

Belial doesn't immediately respond.

She stares at the dust, continuing to twirly her finger around it and draw increasingly larger circles.

"I don't know what I want anymore. Phoebe is dead. She's all that was sustaining me. I failed to protect her. I don't even know if she died from sudden time dilation, or Gressil."

Belial takes a minute to explain the mechanics of time dilation to Cassiel. Surprisingly, Cassiel understands everything and even elaborates at a few points, demonstrating her solid understanding of science and physics.

"Time dilation sickness is a serious matter." Cassiel confirms. "I hadn't thought about it before, but it makes sense. The transition from higher to lower temporal speeds, and

vice-versa, those would assuredly cause adverse reactions in someone unprepared. The fact she was pregnant only increased the risk factor."

"Phoebe wasn't pregnant." Belial corrects. "She gave birth months ago."

"Oh. Well, my point stands. Gressil... probably did not kill her."

"Probably?" Belial asks, raising her eyes from the table to meet Cassiel's gaze.

The two stare at each other for a moment.

"Well. There's always a chance." Cassiel says, her voice lowering. "Especially when it involves *him*."

Belial chews her lower lip. Then she looks away.

"You're the Daughter of Heaven."

Cassiel's eye twitches. Belial's words are not a question, but simply a statement of fact.

"Yes."

"So you're the one who killed Emperor Red Raven?" Belial asks.

"I am." Cassiel answers.

"Then you are in a dangerous situation." Belial concludes, raising her head from her palm. She rests both arms on the table and looks at Cassiel with a surprising amount of tenderness. "All the Archangels are dead. Raphael, Michael, Gabriel, Camael, Uzziel, Uriel, and the most ancient ones, too. The ordinary angels have long since passed into memory. You are the last member of their species, and you're a *Lazarite*. You're more human than angel."

Cassiel nods. "I never truly felt like the angels accepted me or my fellow Lazarites. That is a... fair assessment."

"A lot of demons would like to capture, torture, and kill you." Belial says evenly. "A lot of them. *Especially* Emperor Crow."

Cassiel winces. "I... fought Crow recently. In the Queenie."

"The what?" Belial asks.

"The Queen Network. It's a virtual battlefield made by Amelia and the fairies." Cassiel explains. "You... haven't visited it?"

"No. I don't play games." Belial says. "But you fought Crow there? So she knows you're alive?"

Cassiel quickly shakes her head. "I posed as Uriel, but I did end up using my Lazarite powers. She mistook me for Camael."

Belial scoffs. "Crow isn't stupid. She knows Camael is dead. And since Uriel is dead, you can't go to the 'Queenie' anymore. If you do, she'll uncover your identity. She'll come for you, and she'll kill you."

Cassiel's eyes harden. She grits her teeth and looks down at the table.

"...I know."

"Is that an 'I know' meaning you won't go anymore, or are you implying a different meaning?" Belial presses.

"Gressil captured me after the end of the Energy Wars." Cassiel says quietly. "He... tortured me. Abused me. Raped me. For tens of thousands of years. He broke me in ways I couldn't fathom. I thought I would go insane, especially when that awful *aura* of his kept invading my mind. But, for some reason, I never did. I held onto my sanity, even when I wished I wouldn't. It only made things worse. He broke my spirit, broke my body, and made it so I couldn't even speak."

Tears well up in Cassiel's eyes. Soleil softly rests her hand on her shoulder.

"I... I felt so weak. So useless. More than anything else, I felt like a failure. How could I, the so-called 'Daughter of Heaven', have failed so miserably that I couldn't save anyone? I couldn't even take my own life. *He* made sure of that."

She pauses for a moment to wipe her eyes.

"After... after the Wordsmith rescued me, I thought I could never be whole again. I was terrified of every shadow. I was so scared, so traumatized, I couldn't breathe sometimes. It hasn't been long, you know. It hasn't been long since you and the others *broke me out*."

Cassiel grits her teeth again.

"But... but I just can't! I can't keep hiding away, scared of whether or not that bastard will come to take me away! He's already shown himself to me twice, you know! Twice! He's taunting me! He wants me to feel anxious, to fear him! That sick bast- he gets off on it!"

"So you want to fight back." Belial says.

"I do! I DO!" Cassiel exclaims. "I don't want to be weak! I don't want to be helpless! I don't want to cower in fear just because Crow might come after me, or Gressil, or one of those horrible Demon Deities! I am still sane. I am still capable of doing things to help my species, the humans, even if I'm not as powerful as I once was."

Cassiel heaves a great sigh.

"I don't want to be afraid anymore, Samantha. That's why I approached you."

"You want me to protect you? From Crow and Gressil?" Samantha asks.

"I have Soleil on my side. She can put up a fight against them." Cassiel says, gesturing to her companion. "But I don't know if she would win against Gressil. Sometimes, she departs my side to run an errand or perform a task. That leaves me vulnerable. If I ask you to protect me, that doesn't solve the problem. It simply obfuscates it a little more."

Cassiel leans forward. She balls her hands into fists and presses them against the table, looking at Belial intensely.

"You're one of the strongest Emperors, right? I want you to help me. To train me. I need to become powerful again. I need to become as strong as I used to be- no, to become *stronger*! I need to surpass my former identity. I need to become capable of protecting myself. Only then will I be assured I won't EVER have to fear these ancient demons again!"

Belial leans back in her chair.

She looks at Cassiel with surprise.

"You want me to... train you? But... you're an angel. You only need faith energy to become stronger."

"Faith energy empowers my body. But it's not my body that needs strength; It's my mind." Cassiel explains. "I flinch in the face of danger now. I didn't do that 100,000 years ago. I'm angry, but my psyche is still ruled by fear. I cannot become a pillar for humanity if I'm scared of creatures slithering in the dark. That's why I need your help."

Belial looks away.

She thinks for a minute or two, but it doesn't take her long to come to a decision.

"I need to visit Chrona. I promised myself I would help raise Phoebe's son, Timothy. I can't leave my nephew alone. Every minute we stay here, he ages another 250 minutes. I'll miss his entire childhood if I take a few days to respond."

"Chrona is that place Jason Hiro made, right?" Soleil asks. "Could we go with you? If it's time-accelerated, my lady could make great gains there, and quickly. We'd also be safe from Gressil and Crow, at least temporarily..."

"That's up to Fiona." Belial says. "But I can ask for you. She might say it's okay. Be prepared to be let down, though."

"Sure." Cassiel says, exhaling softly. "Thank you. I... didn't think you'd listen to my request. You're different from what I expected."

Belial smiles and shakes her head. "That's because I've changed. Phoebe and Jason changed me."

She reaches into her bra, one of the few places she can store items given her scantily-clad nature, and pulls out a small glowing button of some kind. She closes her eyes, focuses her mind, and transmits a series of thoughts into it. After a moment, she frowns.

"Is something wrong?" Cassiel asks.

"Well. I just asked Fiona if I could go to Chrona." Belial answers, confusion etched onto her face. "But... she said no. She rejected me. I... why would she...?"

Belial pauses, then she concentrates again, transmitting additional thoughts into the magical button. Her expression falls even further.

"...Fiona says my place is in Realspace. The humans need me. They need a healer and a protector. My strength helps shield them. She says she can raise Timothy on her own. What the heck! I can't believe she'd..."

Belial's confusion turns to anger, and then dismay. She lowers her head.

"No. It makes sense. Fiona isn't Phoebe. They might be cut from the same cloth, but... it was Phoebe I loved. Phoebe is dead. Fiona is... a clone of her earlier self, but she's not actually Phoebe. She probably doesn't have any feelings for me. It seems I was lying to myself, hoping to use Timothy as an excuse to get closer to Fiona. All to fill the void in my heart. She saw right through me."

Belial's shoulders sag in defeat. She stares blankly at the table, seemingly unsure of what to do.

Cassiel, likewise, looks away, somewhat awkwardly.

"I'm sorry about Phoebe's death." Cassiel says. "I didn't know her well, but I know she rescued me. And so did you. I owed her a great deal. If I were stronger, I might have been able to protect her, and the other humans too. Those Volgrim... they caused so much pain and destruction. Maybe even Gressil was involved. These creatures are our shared enemies."

"Yeah they are." Belial says quietly. "I'm sorry. I... didn't mean to get so emotional. I'm feeling helpless right now, bitter about a lot of things. Since I don't have anything else to do, I guess I can work to train and protect you. Fiona's right, even if I don't want to admit it. I'm needed here on Sharmur more than ever. Humanity has lost most of its pillars. Maybe this is my true calling in life."

"Maybe it's both our callings." Cassiel says with a smile.

The three women remain silent for a while, then eventually, they get up and leave.

In the distance, a two-headed figure watches them from inside an illusion. Gressil chuckles softly to himself, then he disappears.

"Oh, my little Birdie..."

Part 616: Meeting the Lowborn

January 14th, 2021. 9AM. Illuminati Haven.

Jason Hiro awoke with a start. For five long seconds, he laid in bed, looking up at an unfamiliar ceiling, feeling better rested than at any other point of his life in recent memory... but also deeply confused.

What a strange dream. He thought. *Who were those people?*

He vaguely remembered something about demons, and angels, and aliens, and... and something else.

But then, after a few moments, his brain fogged up a little, and then it fogged up some more.

He rose slowly, finding himself sitting atop a luxurious and comfortable mattress made of memory foam. His butt sank into the cushioned warmth beneath him, and for a moment he even felt tempted to go right back to sleep.

But the thought of that strange dream kept bugging him until eventually he forgot everything about it. After that, he started to feel annoyed he had forgotten so easily.

"Hmph." Jason grunted, as he swung his legs over the side of the bed. "Where am I, again?"

He sat on the bed's edge and looked around at his barebones but extremely comfortable room. It lacked any personal touches, but the furnishings were all high quality, such as the bedstand made of mahogany or some other high-class wood. A full-body mirror sat at the end of the room opposite the foot of his bed. When he looked at his reflection, it almost felt alien for a moment.

Why am I so young? Jason wondered, before realizing what a ridiculous question that was. *Because I'm only eighteen. Right.*

Those weird thoughts continued to plague him as he got up, shed his clothes, and stepped into the spacious walk-in shower installed in his bathroom. To his surprise, there was only an on-button for the water, and it automatically adjusted its temperature to exactly what his body enjoyed the most. He was more shocked by this inexplicable marvel

of engineering than yesterday's revelations that demons and angels were real and superpowered humans walked among his species.

"Feels like what constitutes 'reality' keeps moving further and further past the horizon." Jason said to himself.

After he cleaned and dried himself off, Jason walked over and sat in a chair beside the door. He stared at the wall across from himself for a while, feeling a sudden pang of sadness. Not knowing why this momentary burst of depression had struck him, he tried to look within himself and uncover the reason, but he just couldn't put his finger on it. All he knew was that he felt as if he had lost something precious, but he didn't know what it was.

Minutes passed.

He slowly stood up, put on some freshly cleaned clothes that had already been perfectly tailored to his body and build, and he stepped outside.

The Illuminati Haven yawned outward before him as he exited his new living space. To his surprise, there was an adorable pale-skinned girl waiting outside with brown hair and a bobcut. She stood at attention, holding a small medical bag with both her hands. She smiled as she met Jason's gaze.

"Hello! I'm Natalie. I'll be your personal liason while you're here at the Haven."

Natalie wore a simple pressed white uniform with blue pinstripes. She had a small hat on her head, ceremonial of sorts, with the image of a golden eye emblazoned on its front. Jason glanced at her for a moment, thinking she vaguely looked like a cross between a military service-woman and a flight attendant.

"A liason?" Jason asked, as he closed his apartment door.

"That's right. I am to follow you everywhere and attend to your every need." Natalie explained. "I'm also trained in hand-to-hand combat. If your life should come under threat, I have to put mine on the line to protect you."

"Oh... I mean, that's really kind of you." Jason said, scratching the back of his head awkwardly. "But, I mean, you don't have to, right? I don't need a... servant?"

"On the contrary. Every Hero who has ever lived at the Haven has had multiple liasons." Natalie said. "Your existence is precious. When you leave the Haven's walls, multiple combat assets will be assigned to protect you. While you're inside the walls, I'm

here to guide you around and make sure you're always comfortable. Please don't hesitate to issue any request."

She winked playfully at him. "Besides. I'm paid *very* well."

It took Jason no effort to notice a slight innuendo in her words, an implication that might have evaded him if he were as naive as he should have been. Clearly, if he wanted it, he could ask Natalie for... *many* different services. It was quite obvious why the Illuminati assigned such a pretty girl to be by his side.

But... they were going to have to try a little harder than that if they were going to keep him on their side. He could never betray his beloved wife.

Jason frowned slightly. *Wife? There I go with those weird thoughts again. Anyway, I'll just keep things professional. It can't hurt to have someone I can ask questions.*

He coughed. "So, Natalie. How old are you?"

"I'm twenty. Born July 4th. I'm from Kansas." She said, tossing in a few extra details randomly.

"Kansas, huh? Never been there." Jason commented. "Alright, so, since I'm new to this place, where can I eat?"

Natalie smiled. "Follow me."

She led Jason down the hall, and several times they passed by technicians, military personnel, and even a couple of the kids Jason saw yesterday. Many of the people gave Jason appreciative side glances, perhaps glad they got a chance to look at humanity's Hero for the first time ever. Jason didn't look impressive physically, but he walked with a strange confidence, as if he had already seen past some of life's vicissitudes. More than a few men who looked as if they had seen combat at some point of their life gazed a little more deeply at him, thinking he had the look of a trained fighter.

Of course, he was only an eighteen year old civilian. That couldn't possibly be the case.

Before long, Natalie led Jason toward an entrance leading into a large, open cafeteria.

"Up ahead, this is where most personnel and the Lowborn Heroes eat. But we actually have a VIP lounge for each generation's Trueborn."

She started to walk past the door, but Jason paused. "I'd like to meet more people. Here is fine."

"Alright. If that's what you want."

As they entered, Jason gestured at the medical bag in her hands. "What's that for?"

"This is for emergencies." Natalie explained. "If you choke on something, or you get struck and end up bleeding, or if someone breaks in and starts shooting, I have some equipment I carry in case of any general crises."

"What, you've got a gun in there? A pistol?" Jason asked.

"Mhm." Natalie nodded, as if that was the most expected thing in the world.

Jason simply shrugged.

He walked over to the cafeteria lane, where a suite of professionally dressed chefs stood behind a line of covered trays. Above them, a long series of menus displayed a dizzying list of entrees Jason and the other Haven staff could order from, with no prices listed and everything being free.

"Damn. This place has some nice perks." Jason commented idly. "I can order anything?"

"Of course. Even if other people had to pay, you never would." Natalie replied.

"I see. In that case... hmm... lamb chops for breakfast sounds good. Oh, that green bean casserole looks scrumptious too, and hey, why not toss in some meatloaf. Natalie, what about you?"

She smiled and shook her head as if he'd asked a silly question. "Don't worry about me, Jason. I eat when I'm off-duty. I have to be ready to protect you in case of any eventuality."

"Oh, is that so..." Jason murmured.

* * *

A few minutes later, Jason held a tray of food with a strong aroma drifting off that made him stomach roar with hunger. He glanced around the cafeteria, and spotted a familiar face sitting at a table along the side-wall.

"Hey," Jason said, as he walked over. "Mind if I join you?"

Brian Bozzard, a pyrokinetic Jason met the day before, flashed a charming smile at him. "Jason! Great to see you again! It would be my pleasure. Come, take a seat!"

Jason sat down, but Natalie remained standing at his side, her hands neatly folded across her bag's handle.

After a few minutes, Jason nearly forgot she was there. Natalie was very good at blending into the background, allowing him to focus on his conversation with Brian.

At the same table, another teenage guy and girl sat across from Jason and Brian. The girl smiled bashfully at him, looking at him with a half-flirtatious look sometimes, and looking away out of embarrassment the other times. The boy beside her looked a little jealous at the obvious affection she was showing Jason, but he didn't say anything uncouth.

"Jason, let me introduce you." Brian said. "The fellow trying to bore holes into your skull with his eyes is Jerome. The girl beside him is Farrah. They are both Lowborn Heroes, like me."

Jerome sneered at Jason, and Jason thought for a moment before recalling that Claire had told him about Jerome the day before.

"I heard you were a real strong guy." Jerome said, flicking his chin toward Jason. "Heard you beat up one of the instructors real good. But you don't look like much to me."

Jason sensed a challenge in Jerome's words, but he didn't feel like rising to it. It seemed obvious Jerome fancied the blonde beside him, and Jason certainly had no interest in her, no matter how pretty she was. Besides, she was much too young for his tastes.

"I'm not strong physically." Jason said with a shrug. "But apparently I'm pretty skilled with a weapon. Dobson seemed alarmed by my talent, said maybe it's the initial manifestation of my heroic power."

"Yeah? You wanna fight sometime then? A little friendly *spar*?" Jerome asked, narrowing his eyes.

"Jerome... don't... don't be mean." Farrah interjected, frowning at him. "Keep it friendly... okay?"

"Yeah. Sure. Whatever." Jerome said, leaning back in his chair. He cut at a piece of steak on his plate and took a big bite of it, staring at Jason the whole time.

"So." Jason said. "I know Brian's power. He's a pyrokinetic. Jerome here grows stronger and stronger every day. What about you, Farrah?"

Farrah looked away, embarrassed. "Oh... my... power... it's nothing much. I can... change my face... a little."

"Change your face?" Jason asked, raising an eyebrow. "What, like a shapeshifter?"

Farrah fidgeted slightly. She nodded, then looked at Jason carefully.

"W-what kind of girl... do you like?"

Jerome's knife scraped across his plate. His eyes remained locked onto Jason as he awaited Jason's answer.

"Hmm... the type of woman I like..." Jason muttered, looking away.

He remained quiet for a few long seconds.

"She'd have to have... white hair... yes, white hair. Short hair, maybe shoulder-length. Strong... muscled... adventurous. Able to beat me in a duel..."

Farrah blinked. "That... that's awfully... specific."

"Yeah." Jason muttered. "I guess it is."

When he looked back at Farrah, he was surprised to see that her hair had shifted color from blonde to white, and her face had aged just a little. She looked slightly different from before, but only seemed to be about twenty.

Nothing about her appealed to Jason, but he still smiled politely. "Oh, yeah, something a bit like that, I suppose. That's a neat ability."

Farrah blushed. "Thank you. It's nothing much. The Emperor of Passion is a... better shapeshifter than me. By a lot."

Embarrassed by her poor performance and Jason's obvious ordinary politeness, Farrah quickly shifted back to her previous self. The atmosphere lightened up at the table as Jerome realized Jason truly wasn't interested.

"So, Jason." Brian said. "What sort of life do you come from?"

"Nothing amazing." Jason said, taking another bite of his lamb chops. "I'm an orphan. My parents died when I was too young to remember them. I've lived in the foster system my whole life."

Jerome's expression changed slightly. "Shit, man. Me too. Damn. Always nice to meet a fellow orphan. You bounced between fosters, or did you find anyone stable?"

Sensing Jerome's accusatory tone abruptly fade, Jason breathed a small sigh of relief at their shared roots.

"Sort of. I lived with a nice couple for a few years. But there was a tragedy."

Jason didn't elaborate further, and nobody pressed him for more information. They felt it was a clear sore spot for him, but Jason merely felt that so much time had passed, he'd somehow started forgetting a lot of key details about 'way back then', even if it wasn't actually all that long ago.

"Yeah. I had it pretty rough." Jerome grunted. "Nobody wants a black boy. They kept bouncing me around. I got in lots of fights. Never lost, either. Especially once my powers started comin' in. But there was one real bad fight, put a guy in the hospital. Started lookin' at facing serious time in juvie. That was about six months ago, when Claire picked me up. It's been a lot better since I came here."

Jason looked at Farrah, and she remained quiet for a moment.

"Oh. Um. Nothing like that... for me." Farrah said, feeling self-conscious. "My parents... still around. Mom and dad. Really nice. Strict, but loving. I'm sorry, I don't mean to b-brag or anything."

"No, no, don't talk like that." Jerome quickly said. "Some people have it rough early on, but that just makes ya tougher, ya know? I wouldn't wish this shit life on anyone, but it happened and there's nothin' I can do about it. It just sucks, man."

"Yeah it does." Jason said, nodding along.

Brian, like Farrah, felt a little self-conscious. "Well, I grew up in a rich family. Stable, I suppose. My mother wasn't really in the picture, but that's because my father kept rotating women one after the other. My life was comfortable, but boring. I guess I had it better than you two at least."

"Being born rich has its own problems." Jason said, waving away Brian's guilty words. "Sometimes, being handed everything on a platter can take away the challenge of life, making you unsure how to proceed forward while becoming your own person. It's no coincidence a lot of rich kids fall to drugs and hedonism."

Brian raised an eyebrow. "You're more well-spoken than I expected."

"Just making casual talk." Jason remarked thoughtlessly.

As the table grew more comfortable around Jason's relatively humble presence, the other three relaxed more and more. Farrah blushed and stammered less often, and Jerome looked at Jason more appreciatively.

"Man, we should spar sometime though, for real." Jerome said with a big smile. His eyes no longer contained their previous hostility. "You're pretty cool."

"I could use a decent partner." Jason said, suddenly looking at Jerome with a serious gaze. "The last guy... well, he wasn't much of a challenge."

"Hah! DAMN! Alright, if you think you've got what it takes, you can throw down with the younger generation's champ!" Jerome boasted. "I'll take you on after breakfast, how about that?"

"You're on." Jason said with a smile. Before he could add anything else, Natalie lightly tapped his shoulder.

"Actually, Jason, before you can join Jerome for sparring, it's essential that we first conduct your Founder Initiation Ceremony. As the inheritor of the Heroic Aura, it's extremely important we do this as soon as possible."

Jason blinked. "Oh? Well, alright then. Guess it'll have to happen later, Jerome."

"Man, you got lucky. Saved by the babe!" Jerome teased.

"We'll see who was saved when I knock you flat on your ass!" Jason fired back.

Not long afterward, Jason finished his food and tossed it in the trash. He waved goodbye to the other three, then Natalie led him out of the cafeteria, her platform shoes clicking on the floor as she walked.

"So what's this founder-thing about?" Jason asked.

"Lady Rothschild didn't inform you?" Natalie asked back.

"No. Should she have?"

"I guess we'll leave it a surprise." Natalie said, shooting him a playful smile.

"Hey! You were supposed to answer all my questions." Jason teased.

"I don't get to have a lot of fun doing this job." Natalie said, flicking her hair lightly. "So allow me to indulge myself, just this once. It's more fun for me if you don't know until the last moment."

Jason narrowed his eyes at her back, but then he shrugged, deciding to remain silent as she led the way.

The two of them exited the cafeteria, traveled toward an elevator, and proceeded to ride down an ungodly number of floors. Jason raised an eyebrow when the counter reached 50, but it kept going right until finally stopping at Floor 77.

"How many floors does this Haven have?" Jason asked.

"A hundred." Natalie said, before winking at him. "Officially."

Jason smirked. He had started noticing just how often Natalie winked at him. He did find it rather adorable.

The elevator door opened, and a familiar woman in a wheelchair was waiting for him at the bottom. Unlike before, Claire Rothschild wore a strange ceremonial robe, colored white with gold accents. On her head, there was an elaborate ceremonial hat that rose half a foot into the air. It looked a little comical, but her expression was so serious that Jason couldn't bring himself to laugh.

On the 77th floor, intricate runes were drawn on the marbled tiles with black and red outlines. These runes seemed to be in a magical language that drew Jason's attention, but he had no idea why they felt so mystical. Pillars rose from the ground at regular intervals, but the floor space was otherwise extremely open and spacious. Various statues of powerful-looking men and women had been erected around the hall, and further toward the center, he noticed a lush underground garden that had clearly been cared for by consummate professionals.

"Jason Hiro." Claire said, slightly nodding her head in a half-bow. "I have already welcomed you into the Haven, but it's time you met the original founders of this place. Or rather, the namesake of the Illuminati, and the initiator of His will."

Jason glanced at Natalie. She remained silent, standing at the side of the elevator with no intention to follow him.

"Uh. Okay." Jason said, looking back at Claire. "He... sounds important?"

"He *and* she. Very much so. Follow me." Claire said, immediately turning her wheelchair around and starting to roll toward the central garden area.

Jason followed after her. Before long, he spotted statues with roses and other flowers growing all over them, but these statues had a strong sense of artistry to them, and the

flowers only further accentuated that feeling. Jason gazed upon carved images of men and women holding swords, hammers, bows, spears, and even one statue of an old man with a rifle. He seemed very out of place compared to the others.

"This is the Hall of Memory." Claire explained, as she slowed her wheelchair's speed down to allow Jason to slowly walk beside her. "Here, statues of every known Trueborn Hero have been carved. One of the goals of the Illuminati is to recover all the ancient artifacts once possessed by these Trueborn Heroes. Unfortunately, many of those artifacts have fallen into the hands of other powerful organizations, the angels, the demons, and others have been lost to time and memory. For the artifacts we successfully recovered, we placed those within the embrace of their rightful owners."

She gestured with her left hand at the image of a young, powerful hero striking a valiant pose, stabbing a sword at the sky. The man wore ancient armor Jason thought might be Roman, or possibly Greek, and in his left hand, the statue held a strange ball of... rope?

"Alexander the Great." Claire said. "His soul was lost when Satan the Devil devoured it. We recovered his artifact, but it had lost its supernatural powers. Even so, we did our best to honor that fallen Hero's memory by pairing his artifact with his graven image."

She points at another statue.

"Joan of Arc. We never managed to recover the Sword From Heaven, so her statue stands lifelessly. But we know her weapon exists, somewhere out there."

"King Hammurabi, another lifeless recreation of one of the most powerful Heroes in ancient history. Known for his wisdom and fairness, Hammurabi wrote down some of the first laws humanity ever followed. We still seek to recover his Law Tablets to this day."

She finally paused before two statues inside the very center of the garden. They depicted a man and a woman, the man wielding a Shepherd's Staff with a circular-shaped head at its top, and an energetic mana orb in its center. The woman, meanwhile, was depicted as sitting on a rock, reading a thick book. Her appearance was quite plump, and her eyes full of life.

"Jepthath, the Illuminator. The father of all Heroes. The first one to ever walk the Earth. The namesake of the Illuminati."

"And beside him, Lady Madam Mildred, one of the wisest Heroes to ever live. A genius who pioneered countless inventions that would not long after form the foundation of the Industrial Revolution!"

Claire paused for a moment. She bowed her head in respect, and Jason did as well.

"I have brought you here to commune with the two ancients, as well as any others in our grand hall. I implore you to seek their wisdom, as you will soon need their guidance to explore the depths of your powers."

Jason nodded solemnly. He looked around, perhaps hoping to see the image of a wise man with a crown atop his head, but he did not see any such statue.

After a moment of silence, Claire coughed into her fist. "I will leave you here with Lord Jepthath and Lady Mildred. I pray your conversation goes well."

Jason nodded, but then he cocked his head.

"Uh, what? You want me to... talk to the statues?"

"The artifacts contain their souls. They are very much still alive, even if only in spirit." Claire explained. "Soon, all will be made known. I must take my leave now. I am not a Hero, and thus my presence here desecrates this sanctum. When you are done, meet with me back at the elevator."

Without wasting any further words, Claire turned her chair around and rolled away, leaving Jason alone with the two larger-than-life statues.

A minute passed. Confused, Jason turned to look at them, and the eyes of Mildred's statue momentarily seemed to flicker with an unknown power.

"*Hah-hah-hah! Well, my dear boy! So YOU are the next inheritor, hmmmm?*"

Part 617: Meeting the Ancestors

January 14th, 2021. 10AM. Illuminati Haven.

Jason closed his eyes and focused. He found his vision drawn to an illusory world made by the power of an ancient Hero, Mad Madam Mildred. In this phantom reality, he stood inside a vast library filled with countless books, scrolls, tables covered in pamphlets, all of it looking clean, pristine, and well taken care of. Candelabras were placed along the walls, their flames colored differently based upon the different contents of the books in their respective area. The library was more dimly lit than any avid reader would prefer, but it did give the place an aura of ancient secrecy.

Madam Mildred stood before him, her plump body contrasting with her somewhat short stature. She looked to be 300, possibly 400 pounds, yet was only five and a half feet tall. She was quite a bit shorter than Jason, at six feet tall. Mildred wore a purple and gold set of Victorian clothes, showing herself to have originated somewhere in 15th or 16th century England, though Jason wasn't learned enough to pinpoint a more exact time or region.

Beside Mildred, a powerful-looking dark-skinned man towered, his arms crossed, assessing the boy before him. His name was Jepthath, the Illuminator, first Hero to ever walk the Earth. He wore humble white shepherd robes, but also armor made of demon bones mounted atop those robes. Resilient, durable, capable of withstanding powerful attacks, he looked to be an awe-inspiring warrior capable of ripping and tearing demons apart with his bare hands.

"Madam Mildred. Lord Jepthath." Jason quickly said, bowing his head quickly. "It's good to see you two again. I mean... it's good to meet you. For the first time, I suppose."

"Hah-hah-hah, what an interesting slip of the tongue, my boy!" Mildred exclaimed, leaning forward to give him a playful smile. "Have we perchance met before? Or have you met another gorgeous, buxom woman who reminded you of me?"

Jason opened his eyes. He looked at Mildred and Jepthath, his expression darkening ever so slightly.

"I... I'm not sure. You seem familiar to me. Both of you do. But I can't place why. I've been feeling this way for the past two days, ever since my powers... awoke? It all

happened so fast. I don't know how to explain it."

Jepthath frowned. "The abilities wielded by a Trueborn are many and varied. Mildred has been watching you since your arrival. We already know everything you have been up to, along with the information you have given our descendants. We have thought carefully about the implications of your words so far, but we have yet to draw any conclusions."

"Oh. That's... good." Jason said hesitantly, feeling a little awkward due to the revelation someone unknown had been watching him this whole time. "I guess that saves me the trouble of explaining myself."

Mildred's smile faded somewhat. She continued to maintain a positive attitude, but she also muted her emotions as she took a good, long look at the young man before her.

"It has been a long time since the last Hero walked the Earth. Not since Harold Whittaker perished to the Nazis have we seen another emerge. This has given our Order a deep sense of existential dread. You see, dear boy, humans have grown more and more capable of fighting the Demons without the power of a Hero, particularly since the Industrial Revolution, but not even the strongest human armies can easily match the power of their Emperors. It is essential we always have a Trueborn in the back-wings, someone who can battle them if need be."

Jason nodded. "Makes sense. Gotta keep our enemies on their toes. Don't want them to grow too cocky and risk unleashing a mass casualty event, even if we do succeed in pushing them back."

"The greed of the demons is their undoing." Jepthath said, a sneer crawling onto his face. "They have grown lazier and more decadent over the years. Right now, they do not feel that humanity, the Titans, and the angels pose them an existential threat. They are mostly satisfied with the status quo. They lounge about, quietly build up their subordinates, and secretly do battle with each other rather than us. They have not seen a Hero appear in decades, so they have grown to believe they will ultimately take over the Earth, given enough time."

"The demons are immortal." Jason points out. "Time is on their side."

"Indeed. An immortal enemy is an enemy who can afford to play the long game." Jepthath said, smiling slightly at the boy's quick thinking. "But it is also a failing they have not seemed to notice. The longer they live, the lower their guards drop. Satan the Devil leads demonkind, but he is a womanizer who loves to sleep around. He thinks more

with his lower demon these days than he did a few millennia ago. Back then, he was a terrifying foe hellbent on destroying humanity and the angels at all costs. Today, he is relatively content to live a more hedonistic life, letting his peers battle for supremacy."

"That might sound like a good thing," Mildred interjects, "but do not let your own guard down, dear boy! The demons have only grown complacent because humanity lacked a hero. Once they obtain news of your emergence -and believe me they will learn sooner rather than later- they will immediately return to their previously vigilant state. Too many Trueborn have unleashed terror upon the demons over the millennia for them to take even a weak Trueborn lightly. Especially as this era has birthed a shocking number of Lowborn Heroes to back you up!"

Jason leans against a pillar and crosses his arms. "You're saying the number of Lowborn is greater than usual?"

"Far, far higher!" Mildred exclaims. "During the eras of Solomon and Arthur, two of the greatest Heroes of all time, there were less than a handful of Lowborn roaming the Earth. Now, there are at least two dozen that we know of, and possibly many more beyond that. I've never seen so many in all my years! Whatever your power is, it must be a 'command' type that boosts other humans."

Jason blinked. "The other people told me that these Lowborn have been springing up for years. They also said they'd been tracking my movements across several continents. But, Lord Jepthath, Lady Mildred... that cannot possibly be the case. I've been right here, in Oregon, the whole time. I haven't been to another state, let alone all the way over in Europe or these other crazy locations."

For a time, the two ancient Heroes fell silent.

"...We have considered this as well." Jepthath said slowly. "I have a theory. I have witnessed many incredible powers in my time among the Artifact-dwellers. I believe you may not exactly be a 'seer' but a 'projector'."

"A... a what?" Jason asked, bewildered.

"Jepthath, you don't really think...?" Mildred asked, crooking an eyebrow at him.

"Exactly that." Jepthath said. "It explains the memory loss and a great many other things. Perhaps, in his sleep, Jason has been projecting phantasms around the world. Unbeknownst to him, before his true powers awakened, he projected ghostly apparitions

of himself in Europe and all these other places. That is why he knows so much about the demons and the other entities. Perhaps he has even observed us without our knowing."

Jason scratched his head. "Uhh... I mean, I guess that's possible. I did- actually, yeah? I had a really weird dream last night."

"You did?" Mildred asks, his voice rising an octave. "Do tell!"

"It's... uh... it was about... um... uhh..."

Jason stuttered and stammered, but no matter what he tried, he couldn't remember the dream for the life of him.

"No memory at all? How bizarre." Mildred muttered. "Dear boy, if you open up your mind to me, I can peer inside and try to examine your thoughts. Perhaps I may even find the source of your power? But I must have your explicit permission before I do so. My power is incapable of being used offensively."

Jason rubbed his arm. The thought of allowing this woman he barely knew to look inside his head unnerved him. But at the same time, he felt even more unnerved by all the bizarre happenings that had occurred since he woke up yesterday.

"I... alright. I'll give you permission... I guess." Jason said.

Mildred didn't immediately dive into his head. Instead, she gave him a serious look.

"Dear boy, I do not mean you any harm. That being said, we are strangers. We barely know one another. If you are discomforted by the thought of a gorgeous woman like myself peering into your most secret memories, then I will not force you. We can always do this on another day."

"We can?" Jason asked.

"Of course, of course." Mildred said, waving her hand flippantly. "You are now being cradled within the protective embrace of the Illuminati. Even if a Demon Emperor should storm inside, our people are among the few on Earth who could protect you. Short of a full-scale invasion, nobody could reach you before our defenses obliterated them. And even if they were so stupid as to attack here... heh heh heh..."

Jepthath's eyes flashed with hunger. "I would be happy to emerge from my artifact for one last bloody battle. Taking down an Emperor would be a noble end to my existence."

Jason licked his lips. He looked away, then he looked back at Mildred.

"Truth be told... I am... curious about these memories... if that's what they are."

"If you do not fully trust me, I cannot look inside your mind." Mildred replied, holding up her palm. "I sense a deep distrust within your heart, dear boy. I will not press the issue further. Instead, why don't we just continue to chat a while? I'll have that lovely Claire bring you back every day for the next week or two. We'll have plenty of time to educate you on the essential matters of this world."

Jason slowly nodded, feeling some of the dread release from his heart. He truly didn't feel comfortable having this random woman looking through his brain. Some sort of primal instinct warned him not to trust others so naively, though he couldn't be sure what caused that feeling.

"Could you tell me about the other ancient organizations?" Jason asked. "They're among the topics I genuinely know nothing about."

Mildred started to speak, but before she could utter a word, Jepthath let out a loud snort through his nose.

"Hah. The *other* organizations? Like the Freemasons? The Rockefellers? All a bunch of charlatans. The fact some Heroes have actually joined them willingly sickens me. Only the Illuminati can be considered the rightful protectors of humanity. My descendants have fought and bled to protect the rightful rulers of this planet, while those other sniveling 'secret societies' sought *peace* and mutual cooperation among our enemies."

Mildred winced. "Ahh, why don't you let me tell the boy about them this time, eh, Jepthath dearest? No need to become so agitated."

"Agitated? Agitated?! I am not agitated just because those prissy, half-witted imbeciles constantly seek to appease the bloodskins! They ought to-"

"Yes, yes." Mildred said, touching his back. "I've heard this a thousand times by now. Let's not subject our dear descendant to another one of your rants. Go take a rest and leave this part to me, hmm!"

Jepthath hesitated. He looked like he wanted to keep roaring about the other societies, but eventually he spun on his heel, grumbled under his breath, and strode away.

"I'm picking up that he doesn't like those other societies." Jason said, speaking the obvious part out loud. "Old grudges?"

"Betrayals, backstabbings... many such things. Actually, his great-grandson founded one of those secret societies. It focused heavily on appeasing the angels and making humans subservient to them, until Jepthath later revived inside his artifact and led an extermination team to wipe that society out. Jepthath will *never* forgive Archangel Raphael for his deception during the Ancient Era."

"What deception?" Jason asked.

"That is a long story." Mildred said. "Let's talk about it later, hmm? For now, dear boy, we should discuss the other secret societies, starting with MJ12..."

* * *

Mildred began to paint a picture for Jason about these various organizations, their origins, their goals, and why each of them were problematic in their own right. Over the next two hours, she and Jason held a long and fruitful discussion on the subject.

"But that's not right." Jason interjected at one point. "By all accounts, the Illuminati is a war-like human supremacist organization. Hasn't it occurred to you that seeking mutual cooperation isn't such a bad idea? You keep telling me how bad the mission statements of these other organizations are, but the Illuminati wants to exterminate the demons, angels, and monsters, leaving only humans in charge of Earth. That's genocide!"

"I know it seems cruel, dear boy," Mildred said soothingly, "but you must understand that we are in the midst of a war for survival. The Demons continue to amass Emperors every century, and the angels build up their army of Lazarites. The Titans, likewise, are far above humanity in terms of individual power. We cannot say how deadly a war against them would turn out. We can only make secret preparations in case such a war does come to pass."

Jason frowned. Over the last two hours, he had learned about Majestic 12, Skull and Bones, the Rockefellers, the Rothschildren and their many splinter groups, the Nazis, the Aryan Brotherhood, the Triad, and even the Ku Klux Klan. He was surprised to learn that in the middle of many of these extraordinary organizations, there were plenty of brutes and thugs that sought only their own enrichment or vindictive goals.

But even so, he grew to think that the Illuminati... didn't sound as peachy and wonderful as Mildred made it out to be.

They were human supremacists.

They refused to cooperate with the demons. They refused to even consider setting aside ancient grudges. They treated Earth as a battlefield that would someday lead to a war of extermination. Only by selfishly empowering humanity would they be able to finally achieve peace.

Jason didn't know why, but that goal did not sit well with him. He had his own thoughts on the matter, and they didn't gel with Mildred's explanations.

Seems it was right for me to not let her into my head, at least not just yet. Jason thought to himself. *Who knows what would happen if she saw how different my thoughts were from hers.*

But on the surface, he simply shrugged, opting to play along.

"You have a point. If it's a war for survival, then compromising with the enemy is not a good idea. I'll have to think more on the matter. For now, I think I've heard enough."

Mildred nodded slowly. "Indeed, dear boy, indeed. Perhaps I have not made as convincing an argument as I would have liked. The next time we speak, I will be sure to rectify that mistake. You can go now, and we will talk again tomorrow."

Jason smiled and nodded. He bowed politely at the waist. "I'm sorry for having taken up your time. Thank you for enlightening me on these crucial matters."

"Hah-hah-hah!" Mildred laughed, causing her massive chest to bounce. "Oh, such a polite boy! Worry not, for I am always happy to speak to any generation's Trueborn! It isn't as if I lead the most exciting life down here! See you tomorrow, dear boy."

Jason stood up straight, and a moment later, his phantasmal body vanished from the library.

Mildred's smile slowly disappeared. She rubbed her chin thoughtfully as Jepthath walked over.

"Thoughts?" Jepthath asked.

"He is unnervingly amenable to the demon's causes." Mildred said. "His mind is strangely firm. He does not have the bearing of a teenager. If I didn't know any better, I'd believe I had just spoken to a hundred-year-old master. He has already seen through the vicissitudes of life. Strange. Very strange."

"Is he a threat?" Jepthath asked, lowering his voice.

"He is no Dracula, not that I can see." Mildred replied. "We will have to continue monitoring him. I will try to make more headway in our future talks. Perhaps I can get him to come around and see things our way."

Jepthath fell silent. He narrowed his eyes into a glare and stared off into the distance, his thoughts unknown.

"Hmmm..."

Jason awoke back in reality. He lifted his head, finding himself standing before Mildred's statue. Without letting his expression give him away, he smiled faintly and turned away, looking as if he were pondering Mildred's wise words.

But internally, his thoughts began to race.

I'm sure of it now. This compound isn't protecting me. It's a prison. They will not let me leave until they're certain they have my allegiance. The whole time, Mildred was probing me, trying to see how deep my pro-demon sympathies went.

If I let her look into my mind, it's possible she'll see all these thoughts and misgivings I'm having now. But if I continue to refuse, she'll only doubt me more. And I can't silence my misgivings, either. The truth is, this 'Haven' is really weirding me out. The vibes are way off.

Jason's smile slipped for a second, but he quickly recovered.

The most infuriating thing is I wouldn't even call myself 'pro-demon'. They're clearly vile creatures. I just refuse to condemn them until I've at least had a conversation with their leaders. But to these whack-jobs, even that is too extreme. They won't allow a drop of compromise with their enemies, so they'll likely resort to more violent measures to get me on their side. Perhaps even... brainwashing.

Jason quickly peered through the reality of his situation. He made several predictions which may or may not have been true, but which felt accurate given his current base of knowledge.

I'll just have to play along while I start working on an escape plan. If I really do have powers, then I need to figure out what the hell they are before the Illuminati do. Once they know what I can do, they'll be able to lock me down even more easily. I can't give them an intel advantage!

Jason met up with Claire. He gave her a brief summary of the discussion with Mildred, then Claire took him back to Natalie.

After Jason, Natalie, and Claire entered the elevator, Jason carefully glanced at his young female companion. Natalie might appear like a flight hostess, but the truth was she was likely there to keep an eye on him and restrain him if he attempted an escape.

I beat Dobson with relative ease. I can probably take Natalie down too. Jason thought.

He continued to chat with Natalie and Claire, keeping the vibe casual, but all the while, he began to think more and more about how he'd make his way to freedom.

Even if I knock out Natalie, there's sure to be other armed guards on the base. I can't make it to the top area if they shut the elevators down. Maybe there's an emergency stairwell? That'll be easy to block off, but at least I'll have a way to escape if I fight my way through. And do they want to kill me? Probably not. They've been waiting for a Trueborn to emerge for decades. No shot they'd kill me and have to wait another 18 years. Maybe I can use that to my advantage.

"Where to next, Jason?" Natalie asked.

"I told Jerome I'd spar with him." Jason said, flashing a friendly smile at her. "Mind showing me to the sparring arena? Honestly, I get so lost in this place. Maybe I could get a map?"

"Natalie will be happy to show you around." Claire responded. "Don't bother looking at a map, it's all just a bunch of confusing hallways anyway."

Jason didn't bat an eye. "Yeah, fair enough."

They must be entertaining second thoughts about me. Jason thought. *I bet the ancestors already relayed my conversation to Claire or someone relevant. I'll definitely have to tread carefully the next few days.*

Not long afterward, Claire split off, allowing Jason and Natalie to travel to the sparring area, where the muscled Jerome awaited.

"Jason! You made it." Jerome said, as he pulled off his shirt to reveal his toned body. "So, you ready to get your butt kicked?"

Jason entered the arena covered in soft and cushy panels, noting the spring it gave to his step. Even if he took a heavy fall, he'd probably be just fine. The glass walls showed

him a few other youths fighting one another in 1v1 battles, but as soon as they saw Jason appear, they stopped fighting to run over and watch from outside.

"I don't know..." Jason said, looking sheepishly at all the people peeping through the glass. "I... don't want to humiliate you too badly in front of everyone."

"Ohh, shit! Little white boy knows how to talk some trash! Alright, alright!" Jerome laughed. "So, we gonna use weapons, or go at it bare-handed?"

"If we use weapons it won't take long for me to lay you out." Jason said, acting aggrieved. "Let's just do a little MMA."

"Oh yeah? A little MMA, you say? You really want to visit the afterlife that badly huh?" Jerome joked. "Alright, toss that shirt aside and let's get moving."

Jason nodded. Natalie walked to the back of the sparring ring and stood beside the entrance, leaving Jason alone. When he took off his shirt, the people outside frowned.

Jason... did not look like a fighter. He was skinny, frail, and badly out of shape. If he weighed any less, people would likely assume he was anorexic.

"Need to get some meat on those bones." Jerome said, before suddenly darting forward. "Don't blink!"

In an instant, their frenzied melee began.

Jason slithered around like a snake. Sensing that he was no match for Jerome in the weight class or strength department, he didn't dare take the brawler on directly. Instead, he snapped out a few kicks and punches, forcing Jerome to dodge. When Jerome punched and kicked back, Jason also ducked and weaved, dodging under those attacks.

But then, Jerome surprised Jason by charging at him like a bull, getting his arms around Jason's chest, lifting him up, and slamming him onto the mat.

"Unf!" Jason gasped.

He struggled to break free, but it may as well have been a toddler trying to escape the grasp of a fully grown adult, for all the audience could see. Jason had no chance. He eventually tapped out, and Jerome pulled away, satisfied with his quick victory.

"Told you." Jerome said, looking at Jason smugly. "Once you get grabbed, ain't nothing you can do. You're too weak."

"Yeah." Jason said, massaging his chest. "You've got me there. Alright, fun's over. I guess we'll switch to weapons."

Jerome smirked. "Yeah I heard you peeled Dobson like an onion, but he's just a *normal* human. Your little tricks ain't gonna work on me."

"Is that so?" Jason asked. "Why don't we spar with... *training staffs*? Best four out of seven. Just gotta knock your opponent to the mat."

"You're on!" Jerome laughed.

* * *

Fifteen minutes later, Jerome scowled at Jason. "Come on! I can't even get ONE point?? Best... best *seven out of thirteen*! I've got you this time!"

Jason grimaced. "Are you sure? Because even if you do get a point, you'll need six more after that..."

"Shut up man! Damn, what are you, some kind of demon or something? How the hell does a staff move that fast?! Ain't never seen anything like it in my life!"

Jerome jumped to his feet. Despite his anger, he was uninjured. He still had plenty of energy, and he could even see that Jason was a little more exhausted than him. After all, Jason's physical strength and stamina were far beneath him.

But when Round Seven played out, Jerome found himself unable to close the distance between himself and his weaker foe.

Jason's movements were precise and calculated. He spun the staff around himself like a hurricane, sometimes snapping it forward to strike at Jerome's abdomen, sometimes to parry Jerome's clumsy and poorly aimed counter-attacks.

In truth, Dobson was a much better opponent with the bo staff than Jerome. Jason quickly realized Jerome was practically untrained. He'd only used the staff for a couple of weeks, along with a few other weapons, before sticking to his fists. All his training was in boxing, MMA, and other fist-style martial arts.

Even then, Jerome was still much worse than Jason at melee combat. The only reason Jason lost when they went full-MMA earlier was because Jason's physical condition was so pathetic. If he were even half Jerome's strength, Jerome never would have beaten him.

Jason jumped forward lightly, swept his staff at Jerome's legs, and sent his opponent tumbling to the mat once again.

By now, dozens of soldiers, students, and other faculty had already lined up outside the glass walls, cheering excitedly as they watched Jason take apart Jerome. Long known as being an absolute tyrant in the sparring ring, few people could get a point or two off Jerome, and absolutely nobody took him apart like Jason did.

Finally, Jerome gave up. He flopped onto his ass and shook his head.

"Man, them rumors was true after all. What the hell? You fight like one of them Kung Fu masters in the Jackie Chan movies."

"Guess I'm just an old soul or something." Jason said, walking over to grab a towel put in the corner by one of the Haven's gym monitors. He mopped up his sweaty body, then sighed. "I'm pretty tired now, Jerome. Let's do this again tomorrow. I've got other stuff I need to be doing."

"Sure thing!" Jerome said, pulling himself to his feet. He also walked over, grabbed a towel, and mopped the sweat off his chest. "Be seeing you around, man."

Jason nodded.

"Be seeing you."

Part 618: Escape!

January 15th, 2021. 4AM. Illuminati Haven.

Two guards outside the Haven stood at attention, one on each side of the entry gate. The silence of the waning night had begun to fade, and the faint glow of dawn had begun to emerge. The two soldiers looked from left to right, always alert. With the arrival of the first Trueborn in decades, they could not afford to slack off.

They did not speak to one another. Cameras swiveled back and forth overhead, searching the jungle for heat signatures and other hostile blips. Each of the guards hefted heavy rifles capable of blasting holes through the bodies of all but the most durable of Dukes. Against Demon Emperors, they might not kill them, but they'd likely cause some pain before the guards met their end.

A bird chirped to the right, causing both guards to snap their eyes in that direction. Reflexively, they took aim with their rifles and narrowed their eyes, looking for the 'creature' that may have made the noise. They were all too familiar with demon tricks, and knew there were all sorts of esoteric and frightening demonic abilities that could easily fool their mundane human minds.

The rightmost guard continued to look to the right, but the left guard instead turned to look in the opposite direction. He realized if something did make a noise, it could have been a distraction to sneak up on the opposite side.

Hardly had he turned his head to look, when a figure suddenly emerged out of nothing, as if revealing itself by stepping through a crack between dimensions. The guard's eyes widened. He started to open his mouth, to shout, to alert his comrade, but the figure lifted its arm and pointed something at his face.

Before he could react, his vision went black, and he collapsed on the ground.

The sound of his body hitting the dirt was enough to draw the attention of the other guard. He quickly swiveled around, only to catch sight of a humanoid figure wearing a black business suit, and a white mask with strange markings he couldn't make out in the dim light of dawn.

An instant later, his vision went black too. He collapsed under the attack of the silent weapon his attacker shot at him.

The attacker smiled under his mask.

"Step one, complete. Let's do the rest right this time."

Recommended Listening

Inside the Haven, all was quiet. The fall of the guards outside didn't set off any alarm bells. Every fifteen minutes, the command center would ping each pair of guards on the premises, getting the secret code-word for their patrol. When they pinged the exterior guards, they received the all-clear without hesitation.

The mysterious mask-wearing attacker grabbed the wrist of the first guard. He placed the guard's hand on the control panel to activate it with his palm print, then he lifted the guard's head up to scan his iris.

Finally, the vocal component of the entryway came up. The suited man leaned over the mic and spoke, his voice changing to perfectly mimic the guard's voice, despite never actually speaking before.

"Jericho-9-0-2."

The gate silently slid open. The man smiled under his mask. He dropped the guard and meandered inside.

Seemingly an idiot, he waltzed right past multiple cameras, as if not caring at all. Despite this, at the exact moment he entered each camera's path, the person looking at that particular camera happened to look away, either to examine another camera's image, or to take a sip of their coffee, or to speak to a coworker.

Coincidentally, time after time, the masked man paused for half a breath, then walked forward, carefully timing his walking motions while occasionally glancing at a wristwatch that displayed not only the minutes and seconds, but even a rolling number of milliseconds as well.

After breaching the base, the masked man casually strolled toward the secondary entrance leading downward. He took a coin out of his pocket and flicked it up into the air.

The coin sailed noiselessly into the darkness of dawn, where it loudly clinked against a metal trash can, causing several people nearby to jump in alarm and turn to look at it.

As if playing a stealth video game on easy mode, the masked man walked right behind the people while their backs were turned. Someone else happened to walk inside right before he did, so he slipped through the entry door behind them, pressed a device to the back of their head, and pulled the trigger.

Their body hit the floor right as the door closed, muffling the noise.

The masked man paused for half a breath. His body blurred slightly, and he mumbled under his breath, "One-one-four, right, left, six seconds..."

He brusquely grabbed the person laying in front of him by their shirt collar, dragged them past three sets of doors, took a right and a left, then tossed the person inside. He silently shut the door, then he began to do something extremely bizarre.

He moonwalked backward, ducking his body as he passed by a window. Coincidentally, at that very moment, someone turned their head to look outside, but they failed to notice the intruder doing an odd Michael Jackson impression just below their field of view.

As if listening to some invisible tune, the intruder began dancing while he walked, bending his body in odd ways, slipping around doorways, dodging one person after another, always evading their line of sight as if he were able to predict the future. Like a ghost, he entered the second level of the Haven, then the third without tripping a single alarm. Nobody saw him even once, save for the guards outside, who remained comatose, unable to move.

Abruptly, the masked man paused as he came up to a door with a numerical keypad.

"Fuck. This is gonna be a pain."

His body blurred. Three seconds passed. His position seemed to remain unmoving, but after those three seconds, he leaned forward and typed in a 12-digit number.

1-1-7-9-5-4-2-7-6-1-2-0

The door beeped once, then slid open.

As it opened, the masked man's shoulders slumped. "Fucking hell. *Fuck*. I'd better not have to do that again. At least the digit only started with 'one' this time."

He cursed under his breath, then slipped deeper into the facility.

Not five minutes after first waltzing in the front door, he smoothly arrived at his ultimate destination. He poked his head out of a doorway and glanced down the hallway outside, where he saw a young woman, only twenty or so years old, standing guard outside a seemingly ordinary room.

The man's body blurred for a moment, then he reached into his pocket and pulled out a small walkie-talkie looking device and spoke into it.

"Natalie, this is Claire. Is the Trueborn still sleeping?"

Natalie Summers blinked. She reached up to touch her earpiece, then looked off to the side, in the opposite direction the intruder happened to be standing.

"He is, ma'am. Is something the matter?"

"Yes." The man said, his voice coming out a perfect recreation of Claire's. "I've just received word that he needs to pay Bloodworks a visit. Please enter his dormitory and wake him up. Get him down here, immediately. His life is in peril."

Natalie's eyebrows shot up in alarm. "Of course. I'm on my way."

She hurriedly turned around and typed in a series of numbers on the door's control panel, numbers the intruder recorded with relative ease. The moment she entered the room, he stepped into the hallway and darted toward the room. His shoes silently struck the ground, far too quietly despite striking hard tiles that should have made at least a slight clicking noise.

Natalie stepped into the room. "Jason-"

She started to speak, but at that moment, something pressed against the back of her head, and her vision turned black. She collapsed to the ground, but the intruder quickly leaned forward to catch her, allowing her to lay down without suffering a dangerous fall.

Jason Hiro awoke with a start. His heart turned cold as Natalie abruptly woke him up, then fell over, a man in a black dress suit appearing behind her.

"What the fuck?!" Jason exclaimed. He had barely even woken up, and already, he felt his life was in existential danger!

In the darkness of his room, Jason couldn't pick up on many details. All he could tell was that the intruder looked to be a male, relatively muscular, wearing a black dress suit

and... was that a mask? A Japanese mask? And why did it have the image of a cat painted on it?

"Who-?" Jason started to ask, but before he could get the words out, the masked man held up three fingers.

"Firstly: I'm not here to hurt you. I'm here to rescue you." The man said, his voice gruff. "Secondly, you may call me 'Cat Mask.' Thirdly: The Illuminati are not your allies. You are right to suspect them. If you want to live free, come with me."

Jason blinked twice. He stared at the man, his mouth agape.

"I-"

"Your clothes are over there. And no, Natalie isn't dead. She's just unconscious. I have a weapon that can induce an abrupt shock to any human's cerebral cortex. It's non-lethal, but only works at short range. Now hurry up and put your pants on. We have seven minutes and fourteen seconds before all hell breaks loose here."

Jason nodded dumbly. His first instinct was not to trust this person, but something about his cool confidence made Jason faintly want to believe in him. More importantly, Jason was already planning to escape. Wasn't this timing... just too good??

Without delay, Jason grabbed a pair of pants. He threw them on, looking at Natalie with a hint of worry, but luckily she didn't appear injured. She simply lay unmoving, her chest rising and falling as if having entered a deep sleep.

Carefully, Jason stepped over her, but couldn't help looking back at her one last time...

"Relax. The pretty girl will be just fine." Cat Mask said with a quiet chuckle. "Now, follow my lead. If I tell you to duck your head, you duck it, got it? We'll be out of here in four minutes and sixteen seconds if everything works out just the way I've planned."

Jason nodded dumbly. "Alright.."

He followed along behind Cat Mask as they power-walked down the hallway Cat Mask came from. Periodically, Cat Mask would do something bizarre, like moonwalking while bending forward, but each of those time, Jason just crawled along the ground. He felt like an idiot compared to Cat Mask's cool and smooth moves.

Two minutes passed. The two of them made it up to the first floor, and Cat Mask abruptly paused. His body blurred for a moment, something Jason had grown used to seeing, though he had no idea what the hell the man was doing.

Suddenly, Cat Mask pulled a walkie-talkie device out of his pocket. He spoke into it, his voice changing to a familiar feminine one.

"All personnel, this is Claire Rothschild speaking. The Trueborn has gone missing. He has attacked his handler and is presumed to be attempting an escape. Immediately surround the second and third levels. Keep an eye out for him. Under no circumstances are you to use lethal force."

Jason blinked. He was internally shocked beyond belief! Cat Mask had perfectly replicated Claire's voice... *but how*? And wouldn't sending the base into high alert compromise their mission?!

Cat Mask looked at Jason for half a beat. "Relax. I've done this a thousand times. We just have to wait eight more seconds, then we'll get moving."

Cat Mask glanced down at his wristwatch. Exactly seven seconds later, he stepped out of the doorway on the first floor right as a pair of men ran past. Jason tensed up, but the two men were so distracted that they didn't notice Cat Mask and Jason emerging from right behind them.

What coincidental timing!

Silently, Cat Mask weaved his way around barrels and boxes stacked around the top level of the base, just outside. He led Jason to the exterior gate, and they walked right in front of the cameras, causing Jason to fear someone might have seen him. But what he did not know was that at that very moment, the guard assigned to check that camera had looked away to comb the level 2 and 3 cameras instead, just barely missing Jason and Cat Mask as they walked past.

After stepping outside the Haven's walls, Cat Mask's breathing sped up. He quickly gestured.

"Come on, kid. We'll have to run, now. I've got a quad outside waiting to pick us up. Let's move it!"

Jason nodded. He didn't know how the hell they were going to escape the entire Illuminati on a freaking ATV, but anything was better than just standing around, waiting for rescue. He and Cat Mask both started jogging as they disappeared into the woods. Along the way, Jason spotted several fallen guards who were supposed to be patrolling the woods. Clearly, Cat Mask had taken them down before he even drew close to the base.

Ten minutes later, they slid down the side of a shallow ravine. Before them, there was an open area nestled inside a natural bowl-like part of the hillside. Jason looked left and right, but he didn't see any sort of escape vehicle.

"We're here." Cat Mask said, retrieving a remote from his pocket.

He pressed a button, and Jason's jaw nearly hit the ground.

A small helicopter, made of a shiny silvery material he guessed was platinum, greeted his eyes. The copter did not have rotors on its top, but instead it was built like a hovercraft with one internal rotor on each of its four 'corners', made for stealth operations. Just by looking at it, Jason had a sudden hunch, a guess that frightened him to his core.

This copter... it's way more advanced than anything I've ever seen! Jason exclaimed internally. *This looks like some kind of air vehicle pulled from fifty years in the future! Or is this a top-secret government copter? Something even the US Air Force would keep under lock and key? Just who the hell is this guy?!*

Cat Mask hopped into the pilot's seat. Jason climbed in beside him via the co-pilot's door.

As the doors closed behind them, Cat Mask turned his whole head to look at Jason.

"Don't touch anything. I mean it. Don't press even one button. I know you want to. *Don't*. We have one minute and forty-seven seconds to escape this airspace. Just sit still, and this will all be over."

Jason nodded. "Okay..."

Cat Masks's body blurred again. Each time it happened, Jason grew more and more confused. What exactly was happening whenever Cat Mask did that?

Jason secretly guessed this guy wasn't a human at all. Maybe he was a demon, or even an angel. Could he be one of the Lowborn? Could that be why he was so incredible at infiltration? Maybe he had some powerful ability that was able to allow him to evade even a monolith as powerful as the Illuminati.

The quad-copter lifted off. Jason shifted in his seat as he felt a few G's pull his stomach into his ass.

Then, the copter turned invisible and shot off into the darkened sky.

"We're not in the clear yet." Cat Mask said, after they had traveled a mile or two. "Hold your questions until I give the OK. The Illuminati have aerial assets they can deploy. They can also call on the local Air Force bases if need be."

Jason's eyes flickered with insight. *So this guy isn't with the Air Force? Is he not even part of the US Government?*

"No, I'm not." Cat Mask said, startling Jason. "I'm a lone agent. Unaffiliated with any other group."

Jason's jaw dropped. "You can read-?!"

"Nope. Not a telepath." Cat Mask simply said. "Now, hold the questions."

Jason bit his tongue. His mind swirled as he thought of a thousand other questions he wanted to ask. Every time Cat Mask spoke, it simply added another layer to the mystery surrounding him.

Just who the hell WAS this guy?!

Minutes later, Cat Mask sagged in the pilot's chair. He exhaled deeply.

"Mission success. Attempts: Seven hundred and fourteen thousand, nine hundred, sixteen."

Jason scrunched up his face. "Huh? Attempts?"

To his surprise, Cat Mask looked at him for a moment.

Then, he reached up and pulled off the mask, revealing his face underneath.

Jason looked at the man's true visage. He was surprised to see that, despite his deeply American way of speaking, Cat Mask was actually a blonde haired Asian man. Korean? Japanese? Jason thought he looked more Japanese than anything else.

The man had narrow eyebrows and a faint mustache. He was relatively clean-shaven, and only looked to be in his 40's. Not old by any means, but certainly a bit advanced in age.

"Hey, Jason." Cat Mask said, smiling at him. "You really screwed things up for me again. Haha..."

Jason frowned. "Do I know you?"

Cat Mask's expression slumped a little. He looked away.

"You did. Once. Or Twice. Or even a thousand times. But it was never destined to work out. That's why I had to leave you behind when you were a kid. It's been eating me up, all this time."

Jason's heart plunged into his shoes. A cold, icy feeling swelled within his chest.

"W-what...? You... you're not... you *can't* be?"

"Yeah. I am. It's me." The man said. "I'm Hideki. Hideki Hiro. I'm your father, Jason."

Silence filled the cockpit. Jason stared at the man claiming to be his father. His eyes trembled.

"You... my... father? No. That's not... my father died. When I was... and my mom, too."

Hideki pursed his lips. As the copter flew, he lowered his eyes.

"I tried to save her. So many times. I went to medical school for hundreds of years. I went back again and again. I did everything I could. But always... she died during childbirth. And she wouldn't let me undo your birth. She told me I had to raise you well. To make sure you grew up and lived a good life."

Hideki chuckled humorlessly.

"In the end, I couldn't even do that much. The fate of the Earth was at stake. I had it all planned out... everything had to proceed according to one path. You would end up in that cryopod and be saved, someday returning to restore humanity, long after my death."

Hideki looked at Jason, an indescribable emotion in his eyes.

"This was supposed to be the last rewind. Everything was all set up. So, Jason... how the HELL did you end up falling into the Illuminati's clutches?! Nothing like that should have ever happened! I accounted for EVERY variable!"

Jason blinked. He pulled away from Hideki, his own confusion mixing with anger and disbelief. "YOU wanted me to be in the cryopod? You?? But- no wait, why would you abandon me? What's this about 'rewinding'? What in the hell is even going on right now?!"

Hideki coughed. He looked out the window and adjusted course slightly.

"Right. Sometimes I forget that I have to re-explain everything every single time. It gets tiring after a while. Luckily I've become the most patient Sentient in all the universe or I'd have gone insane millions of years ago."

Hideki cleared his throat. He continued to look out the window as he spoke.

"I am a Hero, Jason. A Trueborn Hero, just like you. Due to a variety of extenuating circumstances, my Heroic potential passed on to you as a child, and you became capable of great feats. As for me, my power is simple. I am a temporal manipulator. I can speed up or slow down my perception of time, and I can rewind time to any point in the past, provided that moment is not before my 16th birthday when my powers awakened."

Cat Mask's smile turned dour. "I have rewound time more times than you can imagine. I am far older than the oldest living Volgrim. My age even compares to the oldest living Titans at this point. I've seen things you wouldn't believe..."

Jason coughed. "You can rewind time?! Holy shit! That's amazing! But what's this about 'Volgrim?'? I'm going to die of shock-induced heart attacks at this rate!"

Cat Mask chuckled. "It's funny. You say something similar every time we have these discussions. Ah, how some things never change..."

Part 619: Cat Mask

January 15th, 2021. 5AM. Oregon Airspace.

Cat Mask's silver-colored quad-copter zipped across the skies, invisible to the naked eye, as well as conventional RADAR, LIDAR, and other ground-based detection systems. His expression remained easygoing, but his body always had a tense alertness to it.

"So." Jason said slowly. "You're my father. You can travel through time-"

"Only backwards." Hideki Hiro clarified.

"-right, only backwards." Jason said, correcting himself. "And you can slow time down. You also have lived...?"

"A while. I don't keep track anymore. Millions of years, probably." Hideki said, shrugging. "They blend together. I don't have the luxury of being able to look at a calendar to see how long I've lived. I generally segment things into... 'eras' of my life."

"Eras?" Jason repeated.

"Yeah. I've probably explained this to you a thousand times before, but I have nothing if not infinite patience."

Hideki paused.

"I don't really remember the beginning anymore. Flashes. Bits and pieces. I have long forgotten the faces of my mother and father; your grandparents. Both of them died when I was 14, two years before I gained my ability to rewind time. Even if I go all the way back, I can't see them anymore. I still have pictures but... it's just not the same. I don't remember their voices, or anything that would make them more 'substantial' in my memory."

Jason frowned. "I'm... sorry to hear that."

"Don't be." Hideki said with a shrug. "I feel a small sense of loss, a distant nostalgia, but it's been so long that I don't really care anymore. Sometimes I'm not even sure if I count as 'human'."

He chuckled, but the laugh had no soul behind it. "So many eras came and went. I remember when I first discovered my powers, I first started using them to make a lot of money and live the high life. I wooed a lot of girls, met some... some real babes. Not that I

remember any of their faces. Those same girls would be like infants to me these days. Completely unappealing."

The man looked through the glass window, his vision losing focus for a few moments.

"But... I remember your mother. My soulmate. The only woman I ever truly loved. Thinking about her always brightens my day... before turning it gloomy. The light of her smile, the beauty within her eyes... the despair I felt every time she died. It was a cruel inevitability. A 'Fate' that I could not change, even if I wanted. And I tried to save her, Jason. I tried."

"What was her name?" Jason asked.

"Olivia." Hideki said, the corners of his mouth turning up into a smile. "I told countless women about my power. They always believed me eventually, but Olivia was the only one to always believe me, no matter what circumstance I told her, or under what context. She took me at my word and never second-guessed me. She was not as physically attractive as the other women in some ways, but her pure heart was so far beyond them that they could never compare."

Jason listened silently to a story he'd never heard before, at least, not in this timeline. Clearly, his father had told him countless times before, but he had no way of knowing about those other instances.

"It was the damnedest thing." Hideki continued. "I could strike up a conversation with her for the first time under any circumstance. Under a rainy bus stop. Sitting at a nearby table in a restaurant. Even stopping her as we passed in the street. Our connection was... magnetic."

His smile faded.

"I never understood one thing, though, Jason. No matter how many other women I tried pursuing or marrying, I couldn't get any of them pregnant. That is to say, I *could* get them pregnant, but they always miscarried. There was always some terrible complication that killed the baby, or the mother. And no matter how I tried to tweak the variables, every time Olivia and I conceived a child, it would always turn out to be you. Even if we met three years earlier or later, you would always be born at some point. She would always die during childbirth."

Jason's expression dimmed. By the sounds of it, the universe made it impossible to have ever met his mother. The fact his father had tried could not be underestimated. Jason could only imagine how many rewinds Hideki put into trying to save Olivia.

"Failures. All of them." Hideki said bitterly. "We tried IVF, implanting Olivia's eggs in a surrogate mother. I tried recreating powerful supplements from the future, drugs that would startle you with their effectiveness, and many other things. It never mattered. Olivia's pregnancy with you, provided we made love, was an inevitability. Any other woman's, with me, was always a failure. It made me realize that time travel is not as simple as I had first thought."

"You're making it sound like all of this was Fated to pass." Jason remarked.

"That's what I came to believe." Hideki admitted. "And that ultimately drove me to despair. That began a new period of my life which I formally called the Depression Era, but really was a mix of many things."

Hideki waved his hand flippantly. "I grew depressed. I wandered around, living live forty-five years at a time, rewinding when the Earth met its end, over and over. I don't know how many cycles passed. Then came an Era of Boredom. I started learning random skills just to pass the time. I tried dedicating myself to saving the planet. But I always failed. As an otherwise ordinary human, my abilities weren't capable of affecting battles between Demon Emperors and other similarly powerful entities."

"So, I continued to wander. I spoke to every person on Earth at least once. I broke into every building, uncovered as many secrets as I possibly could-"

"Wait wait, you met EVERY person on Earth??" Jason asked, bewildered. "Broke into every building? Dad, there are billions of people. How are you only millions of years old?"

"Oh, maybe it's not millions. Billions, then. Whatever." Hideki said, casually handwaving the sudden order of magnitude increase in his hypothetical age. "Point being, I came to realize I had one terrible flaw holding me back from achieving greatness. Can you guess what it was? Never mind, I'll just say it since I've already heard your guesses. Yes, it was my flawed human memory."

Hideki tapped the side of his head.

"My memory was not made for these terribly strenuous feats of mental endurance. Even if my brain had enlarged and condensed over time due to age, I was still incapable of

storing *too* many memories at once. The ones I did save were imperfect and degraded over time. That's when I realized I needed a way to keep information with me during rewinds."

Jason raised an eyebrow. "I guess keeping a pen and paper on you wouldn't really work."

"I can only bring my knowledge into the past." Hideki said, nodding. "Physical objects do not rewind with me. Not memory cards, not books, not weapons, not anything substantial from the future except for knowledge. My body will also decay if I rewind to a time before I started bodybuilding. So, I came up with a solution after speaking to Archangel Camael."

Hideki flashed a smile at Jason.

"I collected Solomon's Crown from one of humanity's possible futures, then brought it to Camael. I convinced her to melt it down, condense it, and repurpose it and Solomon into an infinite storage and processing matrix for my brain. Because of the pea-sized device's magical nature, it stays in my brain even when I rewind back to age 16. Everything I saw and learned before and after that point crystallized in my memories, giving me perfect, eidetic memory of all my different experiences. I can recall any moment in time with ease!"

Hideki chuckles. "In fact, it augmented my ability to slow down time, allowing me to think and perceive at high speeds even while time was slowed."

"From my understanding of artifacts, wouldn't that have killed Solomon's soul?" Jason asked.

"It would, and it did. But Solomon agreed to sacrifice himself if it meant empowering one of humanity's Trueborn Heroes. At the time, he knew of your existence and the truth behind our lineage, but he no longer does now. I haven't touched the current location of his Crown since that era. Camael, likewise, has no idea of my current identity. Nobody was supposed to, including you, until everything went haywire during this rewind."

Cat Mask's quadcopter hummed quietly as it buzzed to the east, exiting Oregon's border and heading deep into the heart of Idaho, somewhere inside Boise National Forest. This forest was rugged, with countless hills, trees that varied between extremely sparse and barren versus hyper-dense thickets concealing the ground beneath, and everything in between.

The two men passed over winding rivers and lakes, and Jason occasionally looked out at the beauty of nature, feeling in his heart that Earth was much too precious to allow enemies in the future to destroy it.

"I don't get it." Jason said. "Something changed, then?"

"Something big. I'm still not sure what. In fact, the last twelve years have been insane. I've seen Heroic Aura blips appearing all over the Earth. I thought it was you, but every time I drew close to the expected location of one, it disappeared. Whoever it is, he's been evading me with frightening accuracy. None of my stealth measures have fooled him."

"So it's not me and it's not you." Jason said slowly. "How did you become a Trueborn, anyway?"

"We'll save that conversation for after we touch down." Hideki said. "It'll all make sense soon enough."

Jason fell silent for a time.

"What about the Volgrim? Who are they?"

"Aliens." Hideki replied, his expression turning grim. "Ancient aliens who have infiltrated all of Earth's strategic locations. They live among us, look like us, and act like us. But they are not human. The ones we regularly come into contact with are the weakest members of their five species, the Changelings. The others are far more violent, and will someday rain devastation upon our planet in a manner you simply wouldn't believe if you didn't see it with your own eyes."

Jason's eyes flashed with insight. "Aliens? You've got to be kidding me. Somehow, I'm not surprised. Oh! Dad, dad, do you know what my power is? The Illuminati tried to figure it out, but we didn't have any success."

Hideki paused.

"Welll... I do. But it's weird. The Illuminati believed you were a 'seer'. According to the footage I saw, you are also a master of physical combat. This doesn't track with all the times you and I have spent together. In fact, you were always terrible at fighting. Clumsy, constantly tripping over your own feet, and downright unmotivated. I don't know what changed so abruptly, but it's given me a lot to think about."

With a shrug, Hideki continued. "Anyway... your power isn't all that amazing. It's downright weak. We're about to touch down in a minute. I'll show you once we're not at

risk of you sending us falling out of the sky."

Jason blinked. *My power is weak? But that can't be right. Why am I so good with weapons? Am I not a seer after all?*

The copter descended toward a seemingly ordinary mountaintop covered in a thick overgrowth of trees. To Jason's horror, the ship drew closer and closer, until they started flying directly at the side of the mountain.

"Dad- DAD! Wait, wait STOP! AHHH!!"

"Such a drama queen, every time." Hideki teased, as they crashed- no, *flew* directly into the tree cover and passed through an invisible barrier. To Jason's relief, the trees and side of the mountain disappeared, revealing a hidden entryway leading deeper into the mountain, as well as, confusingly enough, a seemingly random cabin near the tree-line.

The copter swiftly slowed down, turned around, and gently landed on a small designated helipad next to the cabin. Jason glanced out at the structure, made from cleanly cut logs by a professional crew, and admired its simple appearance.

"This is where you live?" Jason asked, while simultaneously glancing behind himself at a giant steel door embedded on the side of the mountain. "Or in there?"

"Both. I live in a lot of places." Hideki said, before smiling. "I'm... extremely wealthy."

"You are?"

"Well yes. I already told you before that my power allowed me to make a lot of money. As it happens, I own most of the land on Earth, to differing degrees and through various shell companies. Actually consolidating it all and turning it into liquid cash isn't so easy, but I can always turn in favors to get more land or sell land I don't want."

"Just... how rich are you, exactly?" Jason asked.

"Oh, I'm the richest man on Earth, across all of history. I have no competitors." Hideki said, before his smile slipped. "Jason, I know what you're thinking. You're wondering why, if your father was so rich, I would just abandon you to foster care like a deadbeat. Well, there are... countless extenuating circumstances. I'm happy to explain everything, but it will take a while."

The quadcopter's door swished open, and Jason jumped out, followed by his father.

Hideki cracked his neck. "God, a few dozen years sitting in that seat kills my back every time."

"A few dozen years??" Jason asked in bewilderment. "But... we barely flew for an hour."

"I rewound a bunch of times during the trip." Hideki explained. "We kept getting shot down by missiles, pursued by the Air Force, and I even accidentally drew the attention of a Demon Duke once or twice. Those were the most dangerous moments. Luckily, I found a safe path back, like I always do."

Jason frowned. "Were things really that dangerous? Holy shit. You live a life I can't even fathom."

Hideki started walking toward the cabin. Jason followed after him.

"Like I said. I'm extremely patient. I can explain topics a thousand times without getting bored. It's practically one of my superpowers by now. The number of times I've answered any of your questions is mind-boggling. I'm used to it though, so don't worry."

Hideki nodded away from the mountain, toward the valley below. "The Demon Emperors know I exist, even if they don't know my identity in this timeline. They consider me somewhat dangerous, but don't know I'm a Trueborn Hero. I've been very careful about that. They always have a Demon Baron or Duke somewhere within twenty miles of major civilization points, both to keep an eye on humanity, and to look out for high value individuals like me. It's not surprising they may have narrowed down this hideout's location, but they won't find it unless I majorly slip-up. Of course, if I *do* slip-up, I'll just undo the damage, so it's not a big deal anyway."

Jason scratched his head. He couldn't really argue with his father's logic. If any major error ever popped up, Hideki could just rewind time and undo the mistake.

It was unbeatable, at least in Jason's eyes.

"Say, how do you prevent yourself from dying?" Jason asked, as the cabin drew nearer. "What if someone assassinates you from behind?"

"Time automatically freezes the moment my life is in grave danger." Hideki explained solemnly. "I cannot die if I don't want to. The only time my life was ever in danger was when Camael put me into a coma to install Solomon's condensed Crown-chip, and the time I fought... *him*."

"Him?" Jason asked.

Hideki stopped walking. He looked at Jason for a moment, then shook his head.

"Gressil. The Emperor of Chaos. The most dangerous demon in existence. He has the unique ability to nullify magical powers, including my rewinding powers. When we fought... he came within a hair's breadth of killing me, but then he stopped, laughed, and walked away. He let me live, and I never found out why."

"Holy... he sounds scary." Jason muttered. "Hope I never encounter him."

Hideki pursed his lips. He looked at Jason as if he wanted to say something, but instead hesitated for a long couple of moments.

"I tried to join you, Jason. In the future, I mean. I tried to freeze myself in a cryopod. But Gressil found me. That's the reason we 'fought'. He ripped me out and threw me to the ground, leaving me utterly defenseless. All my martial ability meant nothing when I was shivering and barely lucid from cryo-sickness. Under the suppression of his magic canceling aura, I was completely helpless. He could have snuffed me out. Instead he gave me a command. *Go back or die*. I chose to go back. I never encountered him again."

"That's why... my greatest fear was that he would find you, son." Hideki muttered, looking at the ground. "I had no way of knowing if he would, or could. I built Cryotek myself. I staffed it with trustworthy loyalists and made preparations to hide you under a colleague's protection. But in the end, I had no way of knowing if I had properly hidden you. It ate at me, right up until what was supposed to be my final rewind..."

Hideki continued walking. He and Jason finally arrived at the log cabin not far from the helipad. Jason looked around and nearly jumped out of his skin! He was surprised to see a massive grizzly bear sleeping on the ground not ten feet from the path leading to the front door's entry steps. Squirrels sat on the trees overhead, looking down at him curiously. There were even a handful of cats running around, glancing at him and Hideki with disinterested eyes.

Typical cats, Jason thought.

He nudged his father. "Is-"

"That's Greg. Don't mind him. He's a teddy bear." Hideki said, gesturing to the intimidating grizzly bear. "And I don't mean in the way white suburban moms talk about *pitbulls*. I mean he's literally super nice and loves head scratches. Do be polite and ask

permission first, though, with all the animals. It's not kind to get in someone's personal space and pop their bubble. Everyone here is fiercely individualistic for the most part."

Jason raised an eyebrow at Cat Mask's odd phrasing. The two of them continued up to the front door, and Hideki pushed it open.

Inside, a strange assortment of animal smells and odors assaulted Jason's nostrils. He visibly cringed, though at least he noticed there wasn't any odor of pee or poop. Apparently, someone cleaned up after the animals inside well enough.

The front door opened up into a large living room with modern lights hanging on the walls, bathing the interior in warm orange glow. There were some old but well-maintained brown fabric couches in the center of the living room facing an old television screen. The couches, and several accompanying easy chairs, all hosted a variety of animals lounging around lazily. Some of them perked up when Hideki entered, including a rather large black Labrador with insanely long and woolly hair hanging off his body.

"Oh! Friend. New friend. Hello friend." Someone said, making Jason look around in confusion. He didn't see any people in the house, but what he did see was that same giant black lab looking at him, its mouth slightly open. "Hello, friend. What your name?"

Jason's eyes widened like never before. "What the- you- the dog... talks??"

"Uh huh!" The dog said. "Hi!! I Peppy. Nice meet you friend!"

Peppy jumped off his chair and strode over to Jason, then sniffed his hand.

"Oh. Good smell. Nice smell. Clean human. Hi friend!"

Jason looked at his father in bewilderment.

"Right. The animals here talk." Hideki said, as he strode deeper into the house. "I'm feeling a bit hungry. Stay here and introduce yourself to everyone. I'll be back in a minute or two. Or a thousand. Whatever seems realistic from your perspective."

He vanished, heading into what Jason guessed was the kitchen, and at that moment, the living room exploded into voices.

"Whoa! Guys, it's him! It's Hideki's kid!"

"It's little Jason? No way! He's all grown up now!"

"Never saw him in person. He looks nice."

"CAWW!!! Well, I think his face is too small. TOO SMALL! CAWWW!!!"

"Haha, he seems scared. Why don't we all calm down a bit and say hello to him one at a time?"

Jason swiveled his head around. There were birds, lizards, cats, dogs, all kinds of animals that should have been predator and prey, but each and every one of them looked at him with eyes full of intelligence.

He realized that meant the other ones outside could likely also speak, including the giant bear. No wonder his father phrased his introduction to these animals as if they were humans.

"So everyone here can talk?" Jason asked. "Wait, can ALL animals talk? Have I been missing an important Truth about this world the whole time?"

A beautiful white persian cat walked over the the edge of the nearest couch and sat down. He looked at Jason and slowly blinked his eyes. Jason found the little blue bow on the cat's head to be extraordinarily cute.

"Not all animals can speak. Only ones touched by our Father. However, all animals are capable of complex thought. Unfortunately, due to the suppression of intelligence caused by humanity, much of those gains were siphoned away by your species. Ah, where are my manners? My name is Sebastian. I am one of the Five Great Ones in this house."

"Hi, Sebastian." Jason said slowly, looking at the cat in disbelief.

After a few moments, he managed to get over his initial weirded-out state of mind. So what if animals could talk? It really wasn't anything surprising at this point, considering humanity was apparently in the middle of a war between demons, angels, monsters, and aliens. Talking animals were pretty much normal by comparison.

"Well, everyone, I'm Jason Hiro. Hideki's son, though it seems you already know me. Have we met before?"

"Theodor met you, a long time ago, when you were but an infant." Sebastian said. "Theodor was the first to be Uplifted. He is older than all of us, and has been following the Father for many decades now. He may be of advanced age, but he is quite spry."

Sebastian paused. "By the way, you have my permission to 'give scritches'. We house-dwellers don't usually mind, and will even enjoy it, provided your technique is satisfactory."

A calico cat with multi-colored fur nearby yawned. "Yeah! We love when a slav- I mean, an inferior huma- I mean, a *really nice guy* with good hygiene gives us scritches. It's the best!"

"CAWWW!!!" A crow sitting atop a perch high up on the wall practically screamed. "Well don't go putting your grubby mitts on ME!! I don't LIKE being touched, brat. Got it??"

Jason grimaced. "I wouldn't dream of it. If anyone here wants pets, or doesn't, just let me know. I'm all about consent."

Peppy the black lab suddenly shoved his nose into Jason's crotch and gave it a deep sniff, unnerving Jason. While it was normal dog behavior, it felt *extremely* weird, given Peppy was clearly a sentient creature capable of speaking normally. "Wow! Good smell! Good smell! I like!"

Peppy's tail began wagging happily, while Jason carefully pushed the aggressively friendly dog's face away. "Ahh, consent, Peppy. Consent. Remember? That was... a little weird."

Over the next few minutes, several other animals introduced themselves. Jealous the Rooster, a giant Doberman named Killer who spoke with a gruff Russian accent, and even a parrot who spoke in a sophisticated manner named Edward Thaddicus Riveiera III. Jason found that particular parrot to be rather weird.

As he made his way deeper into the living room and introduced himself to each of the house's many residents one by one, Jason glanced at the giant TV in the center. It was a surprisingly old television, especially given his father's penchant for technology he had built using knowledge from the future. The television barely had a 14 inch screen, its image was purely in black and white, and yet the screen rested inside a massive mahogany entertainment center-sized frame! Why it needed so much space to project such a tiny screen, Jason had no idea why.

As he looked at it, he noticed the program that was visible on the screen was rather bizarre. It was just a TV show of an old man sitting in a rocking chair, out cold, snoring loudly. He was inside some old fashioned house Jason couldn't recognize, and it didn't appear like any classical show Jason had ever seen.

"The heck?" Jason muttered, as he reached for the dials on the side of the TV.

Jason turned and clicked a few of the dials, but nothing changed. The TV seemed to be defective.

All of a sudden, the old man in the TV woke up with a loud snort.

"Huh- hey! HEY! Who's fiddlin with mah knobs! I told you not to- eh? It's some kid?! You damned brat! Who told you it was okay to fiddle with my TV, eh, boy?! Didn't yer got-damn parents teach you any manners??"

Jason took a step away from the TV, looking at the old man in surprise. "What the- you're a person? You're trapped in the TV?"

"Trapped? The hell you mean, 'trapped'?" The old man exclaimed. "I'm jus' tryina take a nap, you little brat! Can't you let an old man nap in peace! Killer, get 'im!"

Jason's heart went cold as the giant Doberman from before stood up and walked over to the TV.

"Father. This boy is Cat Mask's son. He is good boy. Little bit stupid, da. Don't mind him. He meant no offense."

"Father?" Jason repeated, putting an important puzzle piece together. He looked around the room at the animals. "Wait, so, this guy, he's... your 'Father'?"

"Da. Apologies." Killer said, yawning lazily. "Should have explained before. Everyone here too excited to meet new friend. We not see many humans around here. Did not realize you would touch Father's telly-veezion without permission."

Sebastian snickered. "Well, actually, I just wanted to see Father yell at him. I'd have said something sooner, but the opportunity was too funny to pass up."

"CAWWW!!! Tell him off, Father! Stupid ugly boy! CAWWW!!! Don't like him at ALL!!"

Several other animals nodded their heads and snickered, making Jason's expression fall.

These silly animals were all a bunch of pranksters!

"Well dammit, don't be lettin' random kids touch mah damn dials, people!" The old man exclaimed. "Gonna go back to sleep now. Sheesh!"

He rolled over in his chair and mumbled some other things before quickly passing out again. It barely took ten seconds before his snoring became audible once more.

"So..." Jason said slowly. "Who's the old- I mean, who is your 'Father'? Why is he... trapped inside a TV?"

Sebastian's smile disappeared. The cat let out an eerily human sigh.

"Our Father was a great man once. He walked the Earth with his head held high. He fought in the Great Wars. After he died, he became trapped inside the object he coveted most."

"Our Father's name is Harold Whittaker."

"He was humanity's last Trueborn Hero."

Part 620: Harold, The Last Trueborn

January 15th, 2021. 6AM. Boise National Forest, Idaho.

Jason sat on the couch, listening as the adorable white-haired Persian cat, Sebastian, weaved a short tale for him. The other animals remained silent, allowing Sebastian, one of the 'Five Great Ones' to speak.

"Father was a great man. He was known and feared by the demons. His Heroic power made him nearly undefeatable."

"The ability to talk to animals?" Jason asked.

"That was only one component. He also possessed immense strength, superhuman durability, and a body with an enhanced healing factor. He fought in the first Great War, and the second as well. After the first Great War, when he showed off his powers to the world, the other soldiers gave him a nickname. *Captain America*."

Jason scoffed slightly. "The name of a comic book character?"

"The comic book came later." Sebastian explains. "It was heavily based on our Father's exploits."

Jason nodded to himself. It made sense. If Harold really was a super strong Nazi killing machine, it was only logical some enterprising comic book creators might weave parts of his life story into a fantastical tale for children, even if they got a lot of the details wrong.

"So he was super strong, and he could talk to animals." Jason said. "That seems a little bit random as far as power combinations go."

"Harold's ability was not only to speak to animals, but to Uplift them." Sebastian explained. "He granted them enhanced intelligence, unlocking their ability to think, strategize, and communicate. He also greatly enhanced our longevity. Animals touched by Father can pass their superior genetics on to our children. Personally, I am already forty of your human years old. The eldest of us, Theodor, was born not long after Father... *escaped* the Nazis. But, perhaps it is best if Cat Mask explains that part to you."

Jason frowned. *Escaped the Nazis? I thought he killed them all. What does my father have to do with it?*

Jason remembered something else. "You guys said Harold was the 'last' Trueborn. But that can't be right. My father is a Trueborn, and so am I. Wait... does that mean... we're related to Harold? Is he actually my grandfather? Great grandfather?!"

"He... is not." Sebastian said cryptically. "Ah, here comes your father. I think he'd be happy to fill you in on this next part."

Hideki Hiro rounded the corner with a bowl full of milk and cereal. He slurped up a big bite and looked around the room.

"Seems you've all gotten him up to speed on your names, and on Harold. I'll take it from here."

Despite saying this, he remained silent for several minutes, slurping up his cereal and taking large loud bites while Jason stared at him.

"So...?" Jason asked.

"Shush. Gimme a minute. You don't know how annoying it is to have to rewind and re-eat food a thousand times." Hideki grumbled.

Jason nodded. While his dad ate, he glanced at Sebastian. "So where is that Theodor... guy?"

"Theodor is a German Shepherd." Sebastian told him. "He wasn't Father's first companion, but he was the first after the war. The others... died during the war."

"Oh." Jason muttered. "I'm sorry to hear that."

Hideki finished his cereal. He dropped the bowl on a nearby countertop, then burped. "Urrrrp. Cleaning lady will get that later. Alright, so, Harold was the subject, right?"

Jason nodded, so his father continued to speak.

"Well, the story is a bit long. But... suffice it to say... Jason, you and I... we're not 'Trueborn' Heroes."

Jason blinked. "We're not? The Illuminati said the Heroic Aura picked me."

"Yeah, they probably gave you that whole 'Chosen One' shpiel." Hideki said, before shaking his head. He walked over to the couch and sat down beside his son, patting Jason's back. "Sorry, kid. Harold was the last 'Chosen One.' You and me? We're more like... *thieves*. Stolen valor. Not by choice, but that's how things shook out."

He gestured toward Harold's sleeping form.

"Harold was there, in the final weeks of World War II. He was going to storm the beaches of Normandy on D-day. Instead, the Nazis captured him. It was a huge setup, probably a conspiracy involving people at the top of the US government, or maybe even the demons. We've never been certain. What we do know is they took him to a top secret site somewhere in Germany, strapped him to a table, and... *extracted* the raw power of the Heroic Aura."

"They took Harold's power?!" Jason exclaimed in horror.

"They took the Heroic Aura, not his powers. Though he did drastically weaken as a result of losing the Aura. I don't know how the hell the Nazis did it, but those bastards created a super-serum using the Heroic Aura and... some unknown elements. Perhaps demonic magic, or Angel blood, or god knows what. They intended to inject it into their Führer, turn him into the so-called 'Aryan ideal' that he idolized, but one of their top scientists was actually an Ally on Europe's side. He was one of the Japanese biologists brought in by Adolf Hitler to help with extracting the Aura."

"When nobody was looking," Hideki explained, "that man stole the super-serum. Unable to administer it back to Harold, and unwilling to simply throw it away, he injected himself with it. He became a Hero instantly, gaining immense power on the spot. He used his power to tear through the Nazi compound, killing hundreds of soldiers inside the secret laboratory, and ultimately breaking Harold out."

Jason's eyes flashed. "He was Japanese? So... he was..."

"Your grandfather." Hideki said with a nod. "My dad, Ginzo Yamagi, and he later changed his name to escape detection. He adopted the name 'Hiro', had me, and died a couple decades later as a result of the serum's after-effects. My mother died from alcoholism not long after."

"I see." Jason said quietly. "So my grandfather, Ginzo, injected the Heroic Serum, and then passed its power on to you, who passed it on to me. That's why you say we're not 'Chosen Ones,' but instead thieves."

"The Aura's power should not have been ours." Hideki said, sighing softly. "But it is now. There's nothing we can do about it. Harold is already dead, and even though I've studied countless textbooks on biology and other such things, I was never able to locate the research the Nazi scientists used to extract the Aura. Perhaps if I had, I'd have been

able to recreate it... not that it matters now. Harold is dead, trapped in his artifact. I have no idea who the next inheritor should be."

Jason gestured to the giant old television. "*That's* his artifact?"

"In his waning years, Harold spent most of his time after the war watching television. His wife, Helen, took care of him, but for the most part he kept to himself and retired from public life. He ran an animal house where he secretly Uplifted more and more of them, but otherwise, he didn't participate in any further fights. After he died, the world believed that humanity's Trueborn Heroes had perished for good."

"But they didn't." Jason points out. "Whether he did it for the right reasons or the wrong ones, my grandfather became the inheritor of the Heroic Aura. The world never lost its Heroes!"

"I don't know why my father kept his powers a secret, or why he told me to be careful with mine, should I develop them. All I know is he was terrified that remnants of the old Nazi order would find him and steal the power back. After investigating every person on Earth, I can safely say that was never really an issue, but he had no way of knowing."

Hideki slapped his knees.

"So, yeah. That's our story, Jason. Any other questions?"

"Yeah. More than ever." Jason muttered. "But I guess I need to ask the most pressing question. What is my power? Can you tell me now? You said it was 'weak'..."

Hideki looked away for a moment. He sighed, then stood up.

"Let's go outside."

Jason nodded. He stood up and followed his father out the door, but Hideki paused to say hello to the giant grizzly bear, Greg. Greg seemed to grin at him, baring his teeth in an unnervingly human manner.

"Greg, this is my son, Jason." Hideki said, gesturing behind himself.

"Ohhhhh.... your son, huh?" Greg said slowly, as if he were slightly drunk. "I seeee... hellooo, Jason. I am Greg."

"Hi Greg." Jason said, smiling and waving politely. Even if Greg seemed to be a nice bear, Jason felt a little apprehensive about walking over to physically touch him. Greg

didn't make any movements toward Jason either. He seemed content to lay in the same spot, unmoving. He was certainly a lazy and well-fed bear.

Hideki walked Jason away from the house over to the tree-line. He paused to look his son in the eye.

"You're a telekinetic, Jason." Hideki said, pausing to let his son digest his words. "You can project metaphysical force through a few Words of Command. By saying 'Push' or 'Pull' or 'Up' and 'Down', you can move things with your mind. Here, give it a try with these logs."

Hideki gestured toward a pile of chopped logs intended for a wood-fed stove. Jason's eyes lit up.

"So that's it? Really?! It sounds awesome!"

He quickly aimed his palm at the pile.

"Push! Uh... Push! ...push? PUSH! Hmm, am I doing it wrong?"

He tried a few more times, but he kept failing to summon any magical power.

"You have to use your Imagination, Jason." Hideki helpfully explained. "Imagine sending a wave of power flying at those logs when you speak. The rest should come naturally."

"Oh, I see." Jason remarked. He paused for a few moments, then mentally imagined a wake of kinetic energy firing from his palm, like his father explained.

"**...PUSH!**"

Suddenly, a blast of telekinetic energy rocketed out of Jason's palm and slammed into the pile, sending the logs flying!

Jason's heart jumped, and a huge, goofy grin spread across his face.

"It's real! I really can do it! **PULL!**"

He shouted another Word of Command, then yelped in fright as a log came hurtling directly at his head. Hideki lightly shoved Jason to the side and the log flew past him, clattering to the ground behind Jason with a violent *thud*. It nearly killed Jason, but... Jason guessed his father might have witnessed the timeline where that actually happened.

"Thanks." Jason said, a little more quietly than before, as he pulled himself to his feet and dusted his pants off.

"I've seen you die a bunch of times." Hideki said in an oddly emotionless tone. "You and your mother both. It's pretty standard at this point."

Jason nodded, but Hideki's words made him feel a pang of emptiness. Something about the man's casual shrugging off of witnessing his son's death for the millionth time was... so very morbid.

Jason acted a lot more carefully after that. "**Lift. Up. Down. Sideways.**"

He started moving the chopped logs with more precision, and Hideki gave him a strange look.

"What is it?" Jason asked, feeling his father's gaze.

"Nothing. It's just... you're picking up the intricacies of your power more easily than you did in the past. Something about you has changed, but I can't say what, for sure."

He seemed to mull this thought over for a short while, then shook his head.

"Well, anyway. That's it. That's your power. Telekinesis, but it requires you to speak an activation word. It's like what the Volgrim's weakest Psions can do, but the requirement of speaking a word first makes it much slower to activate, and easier to counter. That's why I say it's not a bad or a useless power, but simply too weak to affect the future war in any meaningful way. It's the main reason I wanted to send you to the future, hoping you might someday make a bigger difference there."

Jason looked doubtful. "This is all I can do, then?"

Hideki nodded. "I remember the first time I saw you use your power. It was a shock to me, since I was still deeply heartbroken about losing Olivia for the first time. I'd tried saving her dozens of times before, but decided to simply raise you alone for a while and clear my head. When you used your power by accident and sent a bully in college flying, everything clicked. I finally understood that the Heroic Aura had become hereditary. After all, my father passed it to me, but that might have been a coincidence. Having it happen twice proved the pattern."

He patted Jason's back. "Your power may have nearly killed that college bully, but we quickly learned that while it had some practical uses, it just wasn't at the level of taking out Demon Emperors and other ancient powerhouses. I decided to name it 'Verbal Psionics', and I spent a bunch of rewinds learning its limitations."

Cat Mask spent a few minutes explaining the nuances of Jason's power to him, and the young man's face fell as he listened. It truly wasn't all that amazing, at least not compared to ancient Heroes like Arthur. He could certainly levitate and lift objects of several tons, even sending them flying, but he lacked the fine control that actual Psions possessed where they could adapt their psionics in new and novel ways. By comparison, Jason was a one-trick pony.

"I don't know..." Jason said, after his father finished explaining. "This is *really* it? It's all I can do?"

"I'm sorry, son." Cat Mask said apologetically. "If you throw a three-ton car at an enemy, it will probably kill Demon Barons and badly injure or possibly kill the weakest of Dukes, but against Emperors, your power just isn't sufficient."

Having finally learned the truth of his power, Jason decided to set it aside for now. Later, he planned to do some more experimentation, thinking maybe his father overlooked some crucial details. It felt like he could do so much more, but he wasn't sure to what extent his power could be manipulated.

As the two of them headed back to the cabin, Jason looked at Hideki meaningfully.

"One last question, dad. If you really were so wealthy, why did you leave me in foster care to be... *you know*? Abused, abandoned. I thought my parents were dead my whole life. Wasn't there another way?"

Hideki's footsteps slowed.

"I'm sorry Jason. Truly. I wanted to raise you properly. I wanted to at least give you some material comforts. But every time I did that, you grew complacent. You tried to live a normal life. You didn't want to enter the Cryopod. I constantly faced barriers trying to get you to listen to me. I even considered sedating you and putting you in there by force, but I didn't want you to wake up hundreds of years in the future, filled with hatred. I decided it would only work if you entered the Cryopod of your 'own' volition. And that, in itself, only happened when you felt as if you had nothing left worth living for."

For the first time since meeting Jason, Hideki looks at his son with a truly pained expression.

"I drove you to depression and suicide. You entered the Cryopod because your foster parents had died, you had no friends, and no job prospects. I artificially manipulated your

whole life. It's... it's the thing I hated most. No decent father would want that for his son."

Jason met his father's eyes. He saw a pain he empathized with. Despite not having children of his own, Jason felt that, if he were their father, he would also make a similar choice, given what little he knew of Hideki's powers.

How many times had Hideki rewound time, finding Jason goofing off with his mountain of money, squandering his life away, doing drugs or sleeping with beautiful women instead of caring about a distant future war?

How many times had Hideki tried to reason with Jason, only to be met with the rebellious streak every teenager went through? It would probably have felt like he was banging his head against a wall.

Perhaps Hideki could have convinced Jason to enter the Cryopod eventually, but at what cost? He also needed to set up all the events that would... save Earth? Save remnants of humanity?

Jason felt that if it was the 'him' of three days ago, he'd be enraged by his father's deception.

But today was different.

Jason didn't feel much anger at all. He felt Hideki's actions were somewhat reasonable, as if the whims of an eighteen year old simply didn't apply to him anymore. In fact, even though his father might rewind time again and try to put Jason in the Cryopod, he even had a new idea come to his mind right on the spot.

"Dad." Jason said quietly. "I will enter the cryopod again. If that is what will save the future of humanity, I'll do it."

Hideki turned to look at him, a hint of surprise in his eyes.

"What? You will?"

"Yeah." Jason said, his voice low. "I get it. I see why you'd want to save me. You probably blame yourself for all the harm I've endured. But truth be told, it feels like all of that was such a long time ago. I don't blame you for it. I was a young, dumb teenager. I'm willing to master my power, then enter the Cryopod and come out someday, ready to save whatever is left of humanity."

Hideki remained silent for a time. He gazed at Jason as if looking at a stranger.

"...You really are different." Hideki murmured. "The Jason I know would never speak like this. There's this... strange... sagely look in your eyes. Like you're older than you appear. Did something happen, Jason? Did something change you? Why has your mentality shifted so dramatically on this rewind cycle?"

"I don't know." Jason honestly replied. "Sorry. I just feel that I can empathize with you, as a father, even if I don't have children of my own."

Hideki smiled. He reached out his arms, and then, for the first time since they met... he walked forward and wrapped his arms around his son.

Jason and Hideki embraced, sharing their first father-son hug since they'd met.

Tears welled up in Jason's eyes. He suddenly felt that, despite the mysterious sense of loss that had been haunting him since he awoke two days ago, he'd at last regained something precious, something he didn't even know he wanted.

"Dad..."

"Jason..."

After a few moments, they pulled apart. Jason wiped the tears from his eyes. He was surprised to see that even Hideki looked a little misty as he quickly wiped at his own eyes.

"I.. I don't remember the last time I held you." Hideki said, closing his eyes and turning away. "I hardened my heart. I told myself it was necessary to put distance between us. But... I *regret*, son. I regret it all... so much."

"We can always start over." Jason said, smiling faintly. "You don't have to go at this alone, dad."

Hideki nodded.

"I see that now. You don't have to go in the cryopod immediately, Jason. If you're willing to do so, you can enter later. I would rather... take some time getting to know your new capabilities. It's clear that you're not the same *flippant* boy I originally raised. Whatever has changed, it's made you a better man than I ever could. We can take the 'you' of now and turn him into a demon-killing machine. Even if your powers aren't as strong as I'd like, with some ingenuity and willingness to experiment, we can always find powerful ways to use them."

"I'd like that." Jason said. "I sense my powers have more to them than what you've seen. Can't really put my finger on why I think that way. It just feels... right."

The two men walked back to the log cabin. Hideki paused behind Jason as his son took a few steps up the stairs.

"You stay here for a while. Talk to Harold's animals." Hideki said. "They have a lot they can tell you. Harold too, if he wakes up and doesn't act like his usual cranky self."

"Where are you going?" Jason asked.

Hideki's body abruptly blurred for a few seconds. Then he turned and looked around, his eyes full of suspicion.

"I have some matters to deal with inside my underground base. I'll be back, son."

Jason also looked around, but he didn't see anything out of the ordinary.

Perhaps, when his father's body blurred like that, it meant he had just rewound time several times in a row?

"Dad? Is everything okay?"

Hideki chewed on his lower lip.

"You might have a visitor while I'm gone." He said cryptically. "But don't worry. I'll be nearby. I won't let anything happen to you."

Jason's expression turned grave. He nodded, but secretly, he raised his internal alert level.

Dad is acting spooked. He must have fought a demon sometime in the immediate future, or something similar. I'll have to proceed with extreme caution.

Hideki glanced at Jason. "The animals here are *not* ordinary. If push comes to shove, they can protect you. It would be best not to rely on them, but we haven't had time to train you in using your powers. Be prepared for anything."

"I will." Jason promised.

They nodded at each other.

"See you, dad."

"Sooner rather than later." Hideki affirmed.

He turned and marched away from the cabin, heading toward the metal door in the side of the mountain. After he left, Jason's stomach knit together in worry.

What had spooked his father so badly?

Part 621: Cat Mask's Madness

January 15th, 2021. 7AM. Boise National Forest, Idaho.

As he left the log cabin, Hideki donned his mask once more. He never quite felt comfortable stepping out into the world anymore without assuming the identity of Cat Mask. To those unaware, his actions might seem silly, but countless eons of learning how the minds of his fellow humans, demons, and Volgrim worked had left Cat Mask with one primary belief.

Reputation was power.

A mask was power.

People who saw his face would reflexively lower their guards. He had a kindly appearance, and did not resemble a hardened monster who had killed billions, even trillions of Sentients across the span of his life. His skin was still soft, and his facial hair never quite fully developed into something a grizzled mountain-man should look like.

But the mask he wore was different. He had many masks, not just the one. Each had a different appearance. Some were spooky and weird, some were friendly and kind. Still others were menacing, carrying an entire aura of invincibility all on their own.

As he left the cabin, he put on his 'standard' mask, one that looked like a generic nekomimi spirit that anyone could purchase from a Japanese marketplace. When he was a boy, shortly after his father had passed away, his mother bought him this very mask as a memento to her late husband. While Hideki had long forgotten the majority of 'who' his mother was, he still treasured this mask in particular. It came from a simpler time, an era when he had no grand ambitions, no knowledge of any future wars, and no understandings of the evils in the universe.

But time changed a man. Eternity made him unrecognizable.

Cat Mask had long seen through the whims and wills of other people. He knew how they thought, even if he couldn't read minds. He could understand their intentions by reading the most subtle of facial cues, or the direction they pointed their feet when they spoke, or even by the way they walked.

Everyone wore a mask. He was far from alone in this regard.

Some people wore emotional masks. They put on a strong face while their heart crumbled to pieces. A recent death in the family. A romantic rejection. An unmet desire.

Other people wore intellectual masks. They pretended to be smarter in order to obtain grants and favors. They pretended to be stupid so they could blend in with the lower castes of society. Sometimes, they even acted more or less intelligently just to get a rise out of people. And some believed they were intelligent when they were actually the dumbest people in the room.

Hideki was no different. He simply wore the mask physically on his face. He adopted whatever persona would get him the optimal benefits at any given moment in time.

Jason wanted a loving father. Hideki could no longer provide that for him. After so many eons growing, changing, evolving as a Sentient, Hideki... didn't feel attachment anymore.

And why would he?

He'd watched Jason grow up thousands of times. He'd tried to train the boy more times than he even cared to remember. He saw his son brutally murdered time and time again. Sometimes by demons, sometimes by Volgrim, sometimes even by his fellow humans.

Sometimes, when Cat Mask tried to line things up so Jason would enter the Cryopod, he pushed Jason too far. The young man killed himself out of grief and depression.

Oh well. Cat Mask would think at times like those. *Guess I'll just have to try again.*

And so he did.

He rewound time once, twice, a thousand times, a million times.

He made painstaking notes via the library of Solomon installed in his brain. With its help, he was able to identify all the optimal 'prompts' he could use to change the trajectory of everyone's lives around him.

It was hard to see people as 'people'. In fact, Cat Mask no longer even bothered trying.

Sentients were all so painfully simple, in his eyes. Everyone had a pre-programmed response for certain situations, even if they didn't know it.

"Nice weather today?"

"Yeah, seems good."

How many times had he engaged in these awful, mind-numbing dialogue trees? It was like a video game for him, but in real life. He didn't even know why he bothered trying to save humanity or protect it from destruction anymore.

Why did he care?

What did it matter if all these NPCs died?

Cat Mask thought these things, and many others, for the billionth time. He'd had these mental arguments so many times over his life that it was as if there were multiple versions of himself, all sitting in his Mind Realm, engaged in a pointless, neverending debate.

Cat Mask sighed as the cabin grew more distant behind him.

I want to die.

He was supposed to die a long time ago. He had everything set up. His son would enter the Cryopod, get sent to the future, and all the pre-planned events would occur afterward.

Humanity's construction of the Unified Management Interface.

The Volgrim's invasion.

The deaths of millions, then billions.

The war between angels and demons.

The ultimate destruction of Earth.

And there, at the very end, he would finally allow time to resume as the Earth fell, dying along with it.

But then, on the very last rewind, at the final juncture where all his efforts would finally bear fruit...

It all changed.

Everything went wrong.

Out of nowhere, the entire timestream shifted.

Lowborn humans started appearing everywhere.

Jason no longer entered the cryopod. He was taken by the Illuminati.

"Fuck fuck FUCK!" Cat Mask cursed for the millionth time. "Why did it CHANGE?! I have to start over now! I have to reorganize all the events! Why can't the universe just let

me DIE?!"

He was tempted to give up.

He wanted to throw his hands up in the air, put a gun to his head, and end it all.

He was sure he could do it.

But...

At the same time...

He couldn't help but feel curious. A fragment of his humanity boiled with hunger.

What the hell had changed the world so drastically?

Why had everything come apart at the seams?

He *itched* to know the Truth behind this conspiracy.

"Could it be... *him?*" Cat Mask muttered.

Gressil.

He must be behind this, somehow.

What had that demon bastard done?

Cat Mask approached the mountainside. The massive metal door slowly creaked open as he entered.

The inner hallway that led down into the mountain was massive, far too vast for him to traverse on foot. Instead, he hopped in a small shuttle parked near the entrance, where a robot driver silently verified his identity, then zipped into the mountain at max speed.

Cat Mask loved robots.

Unlike humans, they could be programmed and told to shut up.

Humans always wanted to *know* things. They always had those damned annoying questions.

Sure, Cat Mask answered Jason's questions ten thousand times. But he hated doing it.

He was extraordinarily patient. But that didn't mean he enjoyed repeating the same lines in the dialogue tree known as 'life'.

It was tiresome. So very, very tiresome.

He'd tried other methods. During one particular era, he used a robot controlled by Solomon's Seed to answer all of Jason's questions. Cat Mask put in some earbuds and

ignored his son while the robot answered every little question Jason had.

It was simple. Efficient. Bliss.

The robot possessed all of Cat Mask's knowledge. Anything Jason wanted to know, it told him.

And the result was devastating. Jason saw his father as an unfeeling monster, unwilling to speak to him.

Jason killed himself out of grief. Again and again.

It drove Cat Mask insane.

"Why does he only want to speak to ME?! The robot gave him so much more information. It was the most efficient way to convey everything he wanted to know!"

But he knew why, even if he hated the truth.

Jason was a broken young man. It was Hideki's fault.

He'd put his son through hell. Forced him to live in foster care. Forced him to endure just enough pain that instead of killing himself, he willingly froze himself to travel to a dubious future.

Hideki sometimes felt a little guilty. But that feeling went away.

It was all for the greater good. That's what he told himself.

He knew these were mere platitudes. A minor fraction of the war between his different selves, all squabbling and arguing inside his Mind Realm. They justified his actions one day, only to condemn him the next.

They were the greatest torture he had to endure.

Cat Mask's shuttle rode down the giant shaft into the mountain, a tunnel large enough to fit a skyscraper-sized spaceship, and eventually he reached the end. There, two extremely formidable looking armored robots stood at attention. They scanned him and verified his identity.

These machines were more terrifying than even their frightening appearances implied. Each one was individually as strong as a Demon Duke, and while their production quality was insanely high, the time and resources needed to build just one was truly exorbitant. Cat Mask only had a dozen, and he stationed all of them inside his underground Idaho

base. He'd stolen their schematics from the Volgrim at some era in the distant past and applied countless improvements over the years.

All together, they might have the capital to take out a single Demon Emperor. In fact, he'd done just that a few times.

But it was never easy. The difference between machines and Sentients was always that Sentient emotions could give them huge bursts of power, particularly in life-and-death situations. Push them too far, and they might erupt with 50% more strength than in the previous loop.

Sentients were *such* a pain.

He entered the locked door and the robots slammed it shut behind him. Their ability to validate him came from their detection of Solomon's Seed located in his cranium. Since it was one-of-a-kind, detecting it was all they needed to do, and it ensured he didn't actually have to speak to verify his identity.

Ah, the bliss of silence.

Cat Mask detested talking to other people. He hated it more than life itself, but it was a necessary evil he constantly had to endure. That was easily the biggest reason he loved robots. No backtalk. No useless questions.

Upon entering the facility, Cat Mask emerged into a massive underground area covered in catwalks. Below him, various military craft were under construction, with tunnels spreading out all across Idaho to ship in the goods necessary to build his future weapons. Since humanity could not win the war, no matter what actions they took, the purpose of this facility was not to do that, but instead to stymie the bleeding. Someday, it would form the foundation of a place known as the Remnant Oasis, and it would be run by Cat Mask's most important colleague, Marie Becker.

But that was in the future. The time was not yet right, as Marie and Cat Mask had only established a shallow relationship at this point in the timeline. He glanced at his watch just to make sure.

Still a few weeks on the timeline before my next major interaction with her. Maybe I should try accelerating things. I haven't spent enough time with Jason yet to understand all the changes he's been through. Still need to spar with him and validate his level of martial training. The recordings I took from the Illuminati show he's

suddenly become extremely skilled in hand to hand combat. Bizarre. Very bizarre indeed.

Marie might be able to help me understand why he's changed like this. I can probably get her to invent a brain-scanner or something. Still haven't tracked down the source of those Heroic blips scattered all across the world. If it's not Jason, then who could it be?

Cat Mask walked over to a robot that was hovering a short distance away, taking care not to disturb Cat Mask or speak to him unless spoken to first.

"Butler." Cat Mask said, addressing the small black hovering machine. "Show me the location of the most recent Heroic blips."

"Yes." Butler said, keeping its responses short and sweet. It projected a holographic globe of the Earth before Cat Mask, followed by dozens of white dots scattered across all the continents.

"Narrow down to the last 24 hours. Show the exact times these blips were noted." Cat Mask ordered.

Silently, Butler did as commanded. The number of dots decreased by over 99%, leaving just eight of them, mostly centered on Russia, with a couple dots in the USA, and one in Germany.

Cat Mask leaned forward. He examined the two in the USA, and was unsurprised to see that one of them was right inside the Cryotek laboratory.

"Can't be Jason." He muttered. "Maybe someone observing him? Butler, pull up the security tapes for Cryotek labs. I want to see the video feed for when these blips appeared."

"Yes." Butler answered.

A few moments passed.

Butler's eyes flashed red.

"Error. Tapes unavailable."

"Huh? They are?" Cat Mask asked, bewildered. "Every time! It's always like this. How the hell is this 'Hero' so adept at infiltration? They always cover their tracks."

He looked at the second blip, and his heart turned cold.

"What? Right outside?! Not even ten minutes ago! It's heading toward Jason!"

Hurriedly, Cat Mask rewound time. He quickly jumped backward twenty minutes to just before he stepped inside the tunnel. Instead, he ran back toward the log cabin and looked around, pulling out a hand-scanner to search for the mysterious heroic aura blips.

Jason came outside. "Dad? You're back already?"

"Quiet." Cat Mask said gruffly, irritation on his face. Jason didn't see it due to the mask, but he sensed something was agitating his father.

Thirty minutes later, Cat Mask cursed under his breath. "Bastard. He doesn't show up when I'm here, eh? Then I'll try watching from a distance."

Cat Mask rewound time again. He traveled back to the entrance of the underground complex, then he quickly ran and hid in some bushes, peering at the cabin from across the helipad.

Minutes passed. He stole glances at his Heroic Aura scanner, but frustratingly, the blips didn't reappear.

"You motherf-" Cat Mask cursed, gnashing his teeth. "Oh you think you're cute?! Wasting my god damn time..."

He rewound again. This time, he entered the underground complex and hopped in the shuttle. When he reached the bottom, he kept a careful eye on the heroic energy scanner.

"There!" He exclaimed. "It just appeared! Now to hurry back..."

He instantly stopped the shuttle, turned it around, and raced back up to the top. As he arrived at the exit gate, he glanced at the scanner again.

"GONE?! What do you MEAN, gone?! Why did it disappear?! You sneaking, thieving, skulking bastard of a Hero! When I get my damn hands on you I'm gonna wring your neck!"

Like a game of Cat and Mouse, Cat Mask continually rewound time. He placed cameras around the area secretly, but when the Heroic blip appeared, they were all corrupted and ruined. Cat Mask realized that this entity was capable of long-distance teleportation, something Cat Mask himself was incapable of doing.

"Fuck fuck fuck fuck!!" Cat Mask screeched. "What intentions do you have toward my son?! You think I'm just going to let you hurt him?! Aw, screw it. Do your worst! I'll just

rewind if you kill him anyway! Stupid jackwagon!"

Cat Mask gave up on trying to intercept the Heroic blip. He instead drove back into the mountain to continue his original mission, all the while, keeping an eye on the blip's signature as it approached the log cabin once more.

If the so-called Hero killed Jason, or spoke to him, Hideki would simply find out in a bit, then rewind later to change things. At the very least, he'd have the intel he needed to understand the situation.

He'd done things like this a million times.

Nothing to it.

* * *

Jason sat on the couch, talking to Sebastian about his father. Suddenly, there was a light knock at the door.

"Huh? Is dad back already?" Jason asked. It had only been ten or fifteen minutes since he left. Why would he knock? Why not just walk inside?

Confused, Jason got up and walked over to the front door. When he opened it, there was a teenage girl standing outside, her palms squeezed together, looking at him in concern.

Jason blinked. The girl looked familiar.

It only took him a second to place her face. She was that same girl who spoke to him at Cryotek Labs just a few days before. She was extraordinarily beautiful, with long blonde hair tied up in a ponytail, bright blue eyes that mirrored his, but now she was wearing a military uniform of some sort.

"Uh..." Jason said, looking at the pretty girl. "The girl from Cryotek? Why are you here? Did Cat Mask send you?"

The girl looked at him for a moment, then shook her head.

"Do you remember me? I'm Daisy."

"Daisy? Yeah, you mentioned your name last time." Jason muttered.

Daisy seemed to become irrationally angry because of his distant tone. She stomped her shoe and scrunched up her face.

"That's not what I mean! You're different! You changed all of a sudden! Are you really telling me you don't recognize me, Jason? You don't recognize my name?!"

Taken aback, Jason slowly shook his head. "...No? I'm sorry... miss Daisy... I don't know you. I'm pretty sure I'd remember if we dated in high school or something. I wasn't exactly... popular with the girls."

"Popular with the- NO!" Daisy exclaimed. "Dammit! It's ME! Daddy, it's ME! I'm Daisy! I'm your daughter! Why can't you remember me??"

Jason squinted.

She did look slightly familiar. But. *Daughter*? The girl was clearly unwell.

Jason chuckled to try and defuse the situation. "Ahaha... look, miss, I'm only eighteen, you know? And you seem to be about my age too. I don't know who you've gotten me mixed up with, but I can't possibly be your father."

Daisy glowered at Jason. She seemed uncertain whether he was being obtuse or whether he had genuinely forgotten her.

"My mother's name was Phoebe." Daisy said. "You loved her. You loved her! Don't tell me you can't remember!"

Jason grimaced. The girl was clearly going mad now. He did have that weird thought a day ago that he had a wife, but it made no sense at all. The timeline literally didn't add up. He was suffering from delusions.

Wait. Was this girl a delusion? Was she made up in his head too?

Jason glanced at the animals. "You guys can see this girl, right? Daisy? I'm not hallucinating her?"

Sebastian looked at him like he was an idiot. "No, you're not hallucinating. There's really a girl there. She says she's your daughter."

"Dad! Daddy! Come ON! I tried so many times over the years to test you, see if you'd recognize me, but you never came close. Now you're telling me after you've suddenly changed this much you're STILL ignorant about me?" Daisy protested.

Before Jason could blow off her words again, Daisy suddenly held up a CD.

"I recovered this from the Illuminati. Several recordings of you talking to other people in there. You told them you had a bunch of weird memories you couldn't explain. Dad,

those were REAL memories! They're from the future! The future!!"

Jason fell silent. The words she was saying... they made sense. They explained so much. But they were also too convenient.

Memories from the future? Is that why he was suddenly so adept at fighting with a bo staff? Why he kept randomly thinking about a 'wife' who couldn't exist? Why he knew about various demons despite never having met them?

It seemed a convenient excuse, but Jason realized he already knew time travel was possible. His own father had the power to manipulate time!

Could Jason have also time-traveled? But then, who was this girl?

"You're my daughter?" Jason asked.

"Yes. Your daughter. Daisy. You and mom had me in the future. The FAR future." Daisy explained. "Are you remembering now?"

Jason slowly shook his head. "I don't remember. But I feel like I should. So many weird things have happened to me recently- wait, if you're from the future, then how did you travel to the past? Is time travel just a thing that runs in the family? First my dad, then me, then you?"

"Your dad?" Daisy asked.

"Yeah. He goes by the alias 'Cat Mask." Jason explained. "But his real name is Hideki Hiro. He's my father, a Trueborn Hero. Are you a Hero too?"

Daisy nodded slowly. "I am."

She pointed at her hair. "Blonde hair, blue eyes. It's the mark of the Heroic Aura."

Jason nodded with realization. "If that's true, then... why can't I remember you? Why can you travel through time and remember me, but not vice-versa?"

Daisy sighed helplessly. "I don't know. I arrived here 12 years ago, when I was only six years old. I was picked up by some weird people and then- oh, it's a whole story. It's not important. Dad, we need to unlock your memories! Can't you use your word magic to do that?"

Jason raised an eyebrow. "My Verbal Psionics? But those are only good for telekinesis."

Daisy looked at him in bewilderment. "What the heck are you talking about? Dad, you're a Wordsmith! Your magic is called Wordsmithing! Surely you'd at least remember THAT much! You can make anything happen just by speaking a single word. It's like your signature ability!"

Jason glanced at the room full of animals behind him. Sebastian and the others watched with great curiosity as this unexpected meeting took place.

"Wordsmithing..." Jason said, turning slowly to look at his daughter's feet. He fell deep into thought.

"Yes," Daisy explained. "Dad, listen. You can do anything with a single Word of Power. You were like, the coolest dad ever! You used to do all sorts of tricks for me, and you'd go to any length to make me smile, and laugh and- never mind, that's not important. The point is... you might be able to unlock your memories! Just say it! Say the magic word!"

"The magic word." Jason said, nodding slowly.

He looked Daisy in the eyes.

Her beautiful blue eyes.

One thought appeared in his mind.

She hadn't aged a day.

"**Remember.**" Jason said.

At that moment, *everything* shattered.

Part 622: THE GREAT SHATTERING

January 15th, 2021. 8AM. Boise National Forest, Idaho.

Jason screamed.

A thousand images roared into his brain. Flashes of events that played in and out of sequence.

He remembered his original life. He remembered entering the Cryopod.

He awoke to a pitch-black Labyrinth, hunted by a two-headed monster.

He met a pretty girl who he quickly fell in love with.

He killed her.

He met another woman who nursed him back to health.

He killed her.

He watched as his daughter was born, a girl who loved him with all her heart.

He killed her.

He made friends with a giant, lovable crocodile.

He *nearly* killed him.

Through direct action, inaction, or a failure to respond to threats, Jason repeatedly left the people he cared about dead in his wake.

He professed to hate violence, yet that was always the path he took.

He claimed to love his wife, yet he spent hundreds of years away from her, closed off in another dimension.

He told humanity that he had changed and would become its savior, yet it ended up reduced to ashes as a result of his failure to predict his enemy's movements.

One by one, ten at a time, even thousands at a time, events from his life played inside Jason's mind. He fell to the ground and clutched the sides of his head, screaming and crying inconsolably as his heart ripped into pieces.

Phoebe was dead.

She was dead!

He couldn't save her. He couldn't revive her. He couldn't bring her back!

And now it didn't matter. He had left his future friends behind like a coward and fled to an indeterminate past!

He had-

"Dad! DAD!" Daisy exclaimed, shouting to try and get his attention. "Your thoughts- they're chaotic! Stop, just STOP!"

She pulled his hands away from his head, then pressed her fingers against his temples. After a few long seconds, Jason's vision finally cleared up. He collapsed and lay on the floor, trembling slightly.

"Failed..." Jason mumbled. "I failed..."

"What's wrong? Dad, do you remember now?" Daisy asked, though she could tell based on his surface thoughts he'd definitely broken open whatever dam was keeping his future memories locked away.

Jason closed his eyes. He pressed his palms against his face and curled up into a ball on the floor.

For several long seconds, he gently rocked himself.

"...killed her." Jason whimpered. "I killed Phoebe. It was my fault."

Daisy's worried expression turned grim. She pulled her hands away and stood up, giving her father a long, strange look.

"You... you did? Mom? She's...?"

"Dead. All my fault." Jason cried. "Why? Why did I come this far back? I wasn't supposed to... not what I wanted..."

Daisy's expression dimmed.

In spite of her father's words, she already suspected something like this might have happened. She didn't know anything for sure, but based on the distant memories from her childhood, she remembered that her father and mother loved each other deeply.

If he *had* truly traveled back in time in a manner similar to the way she herself did, there must have been a terrible reason behind it.

"Dad. What happened?" Daisy asked, swallowing a heavy lump in her throat. "Talk to me. Please. I've waited so long..."

She knelt back down and helped her father up. The impact on his psyche left Jason feeling a despair deeper than anything else in his life.

When he lost Phoebe, it was as if a hole had opened up in his heart. He disassociated, unable to reconcile his failures as a man and husband with the reality of his situation.

But now, with all those memories hitting him at once, he nearly melted like a stick of butter in the midday sun. He blubbered and cried while his daughter gave him the most comforting hug she could.

Daisy never imagined this would be how she reunited with her father.

It took a few minutes, but eventually, Jason managed to pull himself back together.

His cries fell silent. He became more stone-faced as the reality of the situation set in.

Tears would not change anything.

"Daisy..." Jason said quietly. "You're... all grown up now. My little girl. I don't... how? How did you...?"

"Daisy pressed her face against Jason's hair. She closed her eyes.

"It's a long story, dad. A long story. I only remember bits and pieces of my childhood. I remember a terrible heat. It burned me, made me feel I was going to die. I wanted to protect you... then everything went black. I awoke in the darkness, and there was... a monster..."

"A monster?" Jason asked.

"Yeah. I try not to think about it. A scary monster. Two heads. Glowing... red eyes... all over its body. It said something to me... I screamed. I ran away. The next thing I knew, I was here."

Daisy squeezed her eyes together.

"But I don't want to talk about me right now, dad. I want to talk about you. Where have you been? Why are you here now? What changed?"

Another long silence followed.

Jason swallowed several heavy breaths. He flicked his eyes around, sensing the gazes of many different animals, all looking at him with great concern. No longer did they have the same lightheartedness about them. They recognized something terrible had

happened. The Jason who arrived less than an hour before was not the one seated in their living room now.

"The day you died was one of the hardest days of my life." Jason said softly. "It changed everything for me. It broke me. Made me want to become a stronger man. Even though I now know you didn't die, I didn't at that time. I had to alter who I was as a human to make myself an entity nobody would ever cross again."

Jason chuckled. "But I failed. I failed, like I always do. Because I'm a useless man."

Daisy listened to her father's words. She heard the maniacal despair at the heart of what he was saying, and it made her weep internally.

Just what had happened to break her father this badly? What horrors had he endured?

Daisy pulled away. She looked her father in the eyes.

"Tell me what happened, dad. Don't hold anything back."

Jason nodded numbly. "Alright."

And so he spoke. For the next fifteen minutes, Jason told his daughter about the future following her death. Beelzebub's detonation. Millions of humans dead. The procurement of Camael's Cube. The rise of the Super Kolvaxians. The attack on Maiura, and the battle between himself and Hope. The final destruction of Tarus II.

Daisy's eyes dulled. She listened to her father, realizing with every word just how badly the future turned out. She had a little brother, but she could never meet him. Her mother had died. It was no wonder her father lost all hope and decided to rewind time.

"The one who convinced you to travel back in time... it was 'Gressil?'" Daisy asked evenly. "Was he the same two-headed monster I encountered?"

"Perhaps he was." Jason muttered. "He was behind this. All of this. Everything. He played me for a fool. But he wasn't a monster. He was a demon. And he's alive right now, in this era."

Jason's eyes flickered with hatred. Deep in the bottomless pit his soul had become, he made a judgment call.

Gressil killed Phoebe.

So what if Gressil said he didn't? Phoebe's death was way too suspicious. And Gressil just appearing like that afterward, taking advantage of Jason at his weakest?

Gressil had to be behind her death. Jason made sure a thousand times that nothing would happen if someone transitioned from normalspace to Chrona. It was always the inverse that caused problems, and he mostly solved even that.

So how could Phoebe have died? How?!

The answer was obvious. Gressil *did* something. He sneaked behind her, assassinated her right before she disappeared, and made it look like an accident. Like it was Jason's fault.

I'll have to find him later. Jason thought, his expression curling into a momentary visage of pure rage. *I'll make him pay*.

Daisy frowned. She saw the look on her father's face, and heard the words in his mind. As a capable telepath, she was well aware of the way other people thought. Her father was no exception. She could hardly blame him for his rage. She felt just as angry, knowing her mother was dead in the future. She felt helpless, knowing there was no longer anything she could do to save her mom.

"Let's focus on things we can fix right now." Daisy said. "Dad... we're back together again. I thought... I thought you'd have to enter the cryopod like before. I thought once that happened, I'd never see you again. I was resigned to watching you disappear and living out my life here in the past."

Daisy balled her hands into fists.

"But I'm not resigned to doing that anymore! You finally have your memories back! You and I, together, we can change the future! We can save humanity from suffering at the hands of the demons!"

Jason fell silent. He lowered his eyes to look at the floor.

"A lot would change if we did that."

"I know." Daisy said. "I've thought about it a lot. You wouldn't go to the future. You wouldn't live the same life. You wouldn't meet mom, you wouldn't have me... but clearly, the fact we're still here- doesn't that imply we've avoided a time paradox? Maybe the future is still playing out somehow! I'm currently working on my degree in theoretical physics. I've been learning about all kinds of important things. Maybe there's still a way we can go back to the future and save mom someday!"

Hearing that his daughter had already started college only depressed Jason further. He looked up at her and sighed.

"You've grown up so much, sweetie. I wish I'd been there. I wish I'd never lost you. I don't know how I can possibly apologize."

"There's no time for regrets." Daisy said, smiling weakly. "What happened, happened. All we can do now is work together to improve the future. We-"

Suddenly, in the middle of Daisy's speech, a pair of footsteps came stomping up the porch behind her. Daisy turned around to see a forty-something Japanese man with a nekomimi mask hanging halfway off his face, his expression frantic with panic, his eyes bloodshot.

"Jason! JASON!!" The man practically screamed. "Oh my god! OH MY GOD! Something happened. Something insane! I can't- who the hell is this girl?!"

Hideki looked at the blonde girl in the doorway. He glanced at the scanner in his hand, seeing that the 'heroic blip' he had been tracking was standing less than a meter from his current position.

"It's you?!" Hideki asked, looking at Daisy in bewilderment. "You're the one who's been stalking my son? Just who the hell are you?"

Daisy narrowed her eyes. "Son? You're Jason's father?"

"I'm asking the questions here, young lady!" Hideki shot back.

"This 'young lady' has a name." Daisy instantly retorted, standing up straight to look him in the eyes. "I'm Daisy Hiro, Jason's daughter. And if you're my dad's father, than that makes you... my grandfather."

Hideki momentarily blanked out. He looked the blonde-haired, blue-eyed girl up and down.

She did have a little bit of Japanese in her, but also appeared somewhat British in some ways. And why was she wearing a Russian military outfit?

No, more importantly, how in the damned dickens could she be Jason's daughter? Hideki knew very well his son was horrible with women. There's no way he'd be able to bed a- no, but the issue was the age! How could Jason have a daughter the *same age* as him?!"

Jason stood up. He sighed heavily and wiped his eyes.

"Dad. The situation has changed. A lot. Everything has been made more clear to me. I know why everything changed when I woke up two days ago."

"It just changed again." Hideki said, standing up a little straighter. "It's a catastrophe, Jason! I can't rewind anymore! Not past about twenty minutes ago! It's like there's a wall blocking my time travel! Don't you see?! Someone screwed up my powers! Maybe it was your 'daughter'?! I CAN'T REWIND, son!"

Jason blinked. He was taken aback by the panic in Hideki's voice. This had never happened in the past, and Hideki was breaking down in real time at the knowledge he could no longer go back to before...

Before...

Jason narrowed his eyes.

"Twenty minutes? That should be about when I regained my memories."

"Memories?" Hideki repeated. "What memories? Can someone explain to me what is going on?"

Jason and Daisy exchanged a glance. Since she was in a better headspace than the other two, she took the initiative.

"*Grandpa*, if that's alright for me to say, it all started a little over twelve years ago, from my perspective."

Daisy skipped over her own life, focusing instead on the moments she traveled back in time, the effort she'd spent after turning twelve to hunt her father down and see if he remembered her, and the life her father led in the future.

Jason interjected once in a while to explain the future events he knew, and the more they talked, the more confused Hideki became.

"So... you're telling me... you both lived 100,000 years in the future?" Hideki clarified. "Then Daisy time traveled back to twelve years ago, and later Jason time traveled too? But Daisy kept her memories while you didn't, son? Now that you've recovered your memories, I can't rewind time?"

Jason shrugged. "That sounds accurate to me."

Hideki fell silent. He tapped into Solomon's Seed and rapidly began to analyze everything he'd just learned. He combined it with an unbelievable mountain of knowledge and information he'd picked up across his many lives.

"So your power is called Wordsmithing. All this time, I held you back, limited your potential, all due to my own ignorance. What a fool I was." Hideki murmured. "I must have succeeded. I sent you to the future, you lived out your life… so now…"

Hideki's eyes metaphorically flashed.

"We're living in a parallel timeline."

"We are?" Jason asked.

"That's right. It all adds up." Hideki explained. "If there's one thing I understand, it's the mechanics of time travel. I used to fear that each time I rewound, I was creating a new parallel timeline, one that continued on without me. But through a series of experiments I performed, I verified this wasn't the case. Whenever I rewound time, I erased the timeline I had just experienced, yet could still remember it myself. *However*, your time travel abilities work differently."

Hideki pointed at Daisy. "Granddaughter, when you came to this timeline, I believe you may have fractured time into two parallel timelines. In the first one, I successfully sent Jason to the future, he had you, and everything played out as you remembered. However, things continued to progress relatively the same, even despite this fact. Even though I immediately noticed the sudden upheaval in events I believed to be pre-ordained, I also noticed several key major events continued to adjust themselves to progress along with my original plans. This means your temporal incursion was not powerful enough to fundamentally alter the rules of the universe."

"So… what does that mean?" Daisy asked. "I wasn't changing the timeline?"

"No, you were, and you did, but if there's one thing I've learned, it's that the temporal plane is extremely resistant to change." Hideki said. "When I laid out my plan to change the future, I had to take into account the 'resistance' of time to alteration. For example, it's trivial for me to assassinate the major politicians currently in power. If I do that, things may change, but we'll just get new politicians who will continue much of the work of their fallen predecessors. If I only assassinate the current president, he will be replaced with another guy who is effectively a carbon copy of him."

"It's like the Hitler paradox." Daisy said, nodding. "If I go back in time and assassinate Hitler, another fascist would likely rise up to continue leading Germany until his eventual defeat. The timeline would stay roughly the same, with only a few details changing."

"Yes! Smart girl!" Hideki praised, looking at his pretty granddaughter with visible appreciation. "So, perhaps if Jason hadn't also rewound time, you would have gone on to alter the timeline somewhat, but the Earth would still ultimately be destroyed, and you'd die within a hundred years, not having drastically changed future events. Your existence would be forgotten, and Jason would have woken up in the future to continue doing things as before, thus merging the timelines back together."

Jason rubbed his chin. "So... the temporal plane would usually repair itself to try and prevent paradoxes?"

"Exactly." Hideki said, before his expression fell. "But that isn't the case anymore. Jason, if I cannot rewind past twenty minutes ago, it may indicate something truly unprecedented has happened. You remembering the future may have fundamentally *broken* the temporal plane. I don't know why only you would cause this, and not Daisy. She time traveled from the future and kept her memories, yet she did not cause as significant a temporal event as you."

Jason looked back and forth from his daughter to his father.

"It might be... because of my powers." Jason muttered. "My power is Wordsmithing. It's fundamentally different, and more powerful, than whatever Daisy has. Speaking of which, Daisy, what ARE your powers?"

Daisy massaged her forehead. "I have quite a few, dad. A veritable grab-bag. They aren't as 'many' as the abilities your Wordsmithing can unleash, but they're still pretty potent. I can show you later, once we've figured out all this time-stuff."

Jason smiled. He touched his daughter's shoulder and nodded.

"You're right. We have plenty of time to catch up. I have so much to tell you. To talk about. But right now, we need to deal with these important issues."

He returned his attention to Hideki.

"Let's assume for the sake of argument that me recovering my memories somehow broke the timeline or whatever. What is the significance? Can we use this to our advantage?"

Hideki raised an eyebrow.

"Son, if I had *known* that your power was 'Wordsmithing' and that it had such an insane level of versatility, I'd never have put you in that cryopod. If anything, that's probably why I can no longer rewind past the moment you recovered your memories. Knowing what you can do, it changes the entire flow of future events. I'm going to have to think long and hard about adjusting all my plans and strategies."

Hideki chuckled.

"I can't stress this enough. We have a real shot at *winning* this war now. Defeating the Volgrim. Saving the Earth. And to think, all this time I just... tsk. Can't believe I was so dense. I really held you back, son. Let you down."

Hideki looked at Daisy again and shook his head.

"A whole-ass granddaughter out of nowhere. This really is a Bizarro timeline."

Jason nodded along to his father's words.

"You're not the only one who needs to do some thinking, dad. I do too. I need to think about a lot of things. I never intended to rewind all the way back to when I was eighteen, before I entered the Cryopod. But now that I'm here, I intend to make the most of my situation."

A flame of rage burned inside Jason's soul as he recalled the smoldering ruins of Tarus II.

"The Volgrim are going to pay *dearly* for their betrayal."

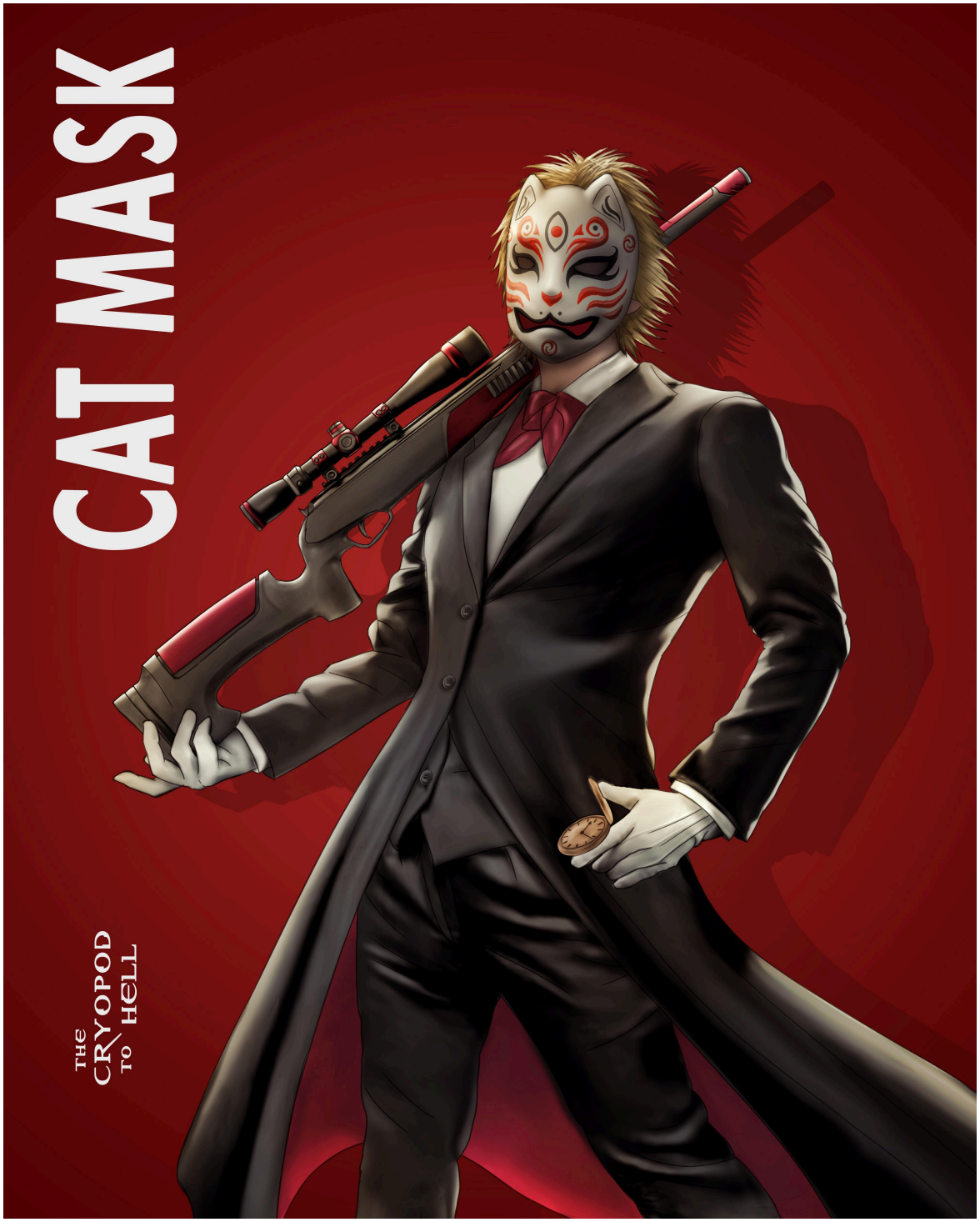
Author Notes:

Here is artwork of Daisy Hiro and Hideki Hiro.

Soviet Daisy:

Athletic Daisy:

Cat Mask:



Alt Mask:

THE CRYOPOD TO HELL
CAT MASK

Part 623: Hiro Stratagem

January 15th, 2021. Noon. Boise National Forest, Idaho.

A few hours passed.

Jason, Daisy, and Hideki all sat at a table, discussing a variety of things, now having caught up on the events of their lives.

Jason looked at his daughter's brown and red military uniform. Her distinctive red hat with a bright red star on its top told him an entire story about the life she'd lived.

"So the Russians picked you up?"

Daisy nodded. "I don't know why, but when I time-traveled, I arrived in a random city in Europe. I was too young to understand what happened. I was naked and alone, so I drew a lot of attention. These two strange men immediately took an... *interest*... in me. I freaked out. I killed them."

Daisy's eyes dimmed.

"I still don't know what I did. I had no real control of my powers at the time. I obliterated their bodies. Reduced them to... raggedy chunks of meat. Looking back, thinking on what their intentions probably were, I now feel their deaths were deserved. But it was still... traumatizing."

Jason pursed his lips. He couldn't bring himself to look his daughter in the eyes. The sense of guilt he felt at never guessing she went back in time was, of course, completely irrational. But he still felt responsible for what happened. If he had fought the demons properly, worked harder on his powers, and been a better father, she'd never have been put in a situation where she time traveled.

"Yeah." Jason muttered. "You're right. They did deserve to die. I just wish you hadn't been the one killing them. Children shouldn't experience such things."

"Well, it happened. No way to change it now." Daisy said, grabbing a glass of orange juice off the table and taking a sip. "After that, the people nearby freaked out. This all took place in a relatively public area. The police were called, but they were too terrified to apprehend me. People were shouting, yelling in a language I couldn't understand. Their

thoughts screamed unintelligible words at me. I panicked. I ran. Then I teleported, and teleported again."

"I don't know how many times I randomly teleported. Eventually, I arrived in Moscow." Daisy explained. "I was tired. Exhausted. Scared and cold. I still had no clothes. I crawled into a dumpster and closed the lid, then fell asleep. I awoke to the lip opening and some people stabbing me with an electrical rod. They tased me. Captured me. Took me somewhere secret, kept me drugged up. Experimented on me."

Daisy's eyes flickered. A deep look of fear and rage momentarily surfaced, but she tamped it down.

"I think I was in their custody for... a year or two. Suffering day in and out. They turned me into their pet monkey. Made me use my powers. Hurt me if I didn't comply. Lightly rewarded me when I did. I lost all hope. I couldn't escape. Something about an anti-magic field made it so I couldn't teleport outside. Then everything changed one day when a certain influential man showed up. He heard about my plight and asked to see me. He adopted me, and had that entire horrid facility shut down. Later, I found he even had many of the scientists executed."

Daisy smiled wistfully.

"Uncle Vasily Sokolov. He finally saved me from that hell. I was like a beaten puppy. I was too afraid to run. Too scared to hide. He treated me like a human again, helped me open up out of my shell. He became my anchor and support."

Jason smiled. "I'm... glad. I hate that you suffered for two years. Two long years... my little girl. At least there was someone good in your life."

Hideki, watching from the side, frowned. "Vasily Sokolov, you said? One of Russia's Deputy Ministers?"

Daisy nodded slightly. "You know him, grandpa?"

Hideki coughed at the mention of being a grandfather, but considering he was mentally billions of years old, it wasn't that weird. "Oh, I know him alright. You say he's a kind man?"

Daisy narrowed her eyes. She easily picked up on some surface thoughts swimming in Hideki's mind.

"I don't know what future you saw, but Uncle Vasily is a good man. He's a kind man. He supports law and order. And he's *not* the president's lapdog. We've been working on ways to... correct... Russia's internal political situation."

"I've seen a lot of possible futures." Hideki muttered, looking his granddaughter in the eyes. "I don't recall a single one where he became a saint."

"Dad, come on." Jason interjected. "Let's cut the guy a break. He saved my daughter. I at least owe him enough respect to meet and speak to him before judging him."

"I..." Hideki started to say, before giving up mid-sentence. "Sure, Jason. We can do that."

Daisy glared at Hideki for a moment before looking back at her father. Her expression immediately became warmer. It was clear to her that, even if her father's appearance was not the same, he was the same kind and forgiving man she knew as a child.

"Well. Enough about me, dad." Daisy said. "What are we going to do now? What's our game plan, moving forward?"

Jason didn't immediately answer.

He turned his head slightly and looked out the window, feeling momentarily lost.

"There's... so many things I want to do. I don't even know where to start." Jason said slowly. "Saving the Earth is essential. I refuse to believe with the knowledge I have of future events and players that I can't create contingency plans. Perhaps my highest priority is to regain all the strength I had at my peak... before my battle with Hope. That power was not enough to protect me from the Volgrim, but it's a good starting point."

Hideki appeared glad to change the topic. "That 'Star-Net' you mentioned seemed extremely powerful."

"The Star Net took over two hundred time-accelerated years to build, and it was incomplete." Jason said slowly. "I couldn't have made it without Fiona and Rebecca's help. Fiona is still in the future timeline. The Rebecca of this era probably isn't advanced enough to provide me the assistance I'd need. I'll need to remake the Star-Net and other technologies through my own efforts."

Jason massaged his chin as he fell into thought.

"Marie Becker. She's in this era, right? She can help me."

"That is not advisable." Hideki immediately interjected. "Marie Becker has much to do. Until she completes the creation of the Unified Management Interface, Earth will always be vulnerable. UMI by itself is capable of pushing back the Volgrim invasion multiple decades, at least in the best case scenario. I don't know how much things are going to change, but if I ignore your failure to enter the cryopod, most of the timeline is still intact."

"Can you brief me on the timeline?" Jason asked.

"I could..." Hideki said, his tone hesitant. "But it might not be a good idea. I could only tell you what I expect to happen, but by telling you, I would immediately change the future. Informing people of future events will always alter those events, provided they believe I am a time traveler."

"So you won't tell me?" Jason pressed further.

Hideki scratched his head. He looked pained by Jason's request. Further, he knew Daisy was reading his mind, so even just thinking about the future was already influencing it.

"There are going to be several major events that are difficult for me to change, possibly not you." Hideki finally said. "As we speak, the Volgrim are already on Earth. Changelings are everywhere. They're our CEOs, politicians, presidents, media moguls, and just plain ordinary citizens. You kill one, another takes its place. As of this moment, there are about nine million, seven hundred thousand of them living across all the different continents. They collect intelligence on humanity and the other Sentients alike."

Cat Mask continued. "Right now, almost none of the other Volgrim subspecies are paying attention to Earth. However, there is a vessel monitoring our planet from beyond Jupiter's orbit. This vessel is considered an unimportant, low-ranking Psion scouting ship. Over the next several years, it will be relegated to an otherwise low-level assignment, and will not make any direct moves to poke at Earth. But if humanity advances too quickly, especially as a result of my intervention or yours, the ship will 'activate' sooner. It could bring the apocalypse down upon our heads decades sooner, well before we're ready to fight back."

Jason nodded. "You've interacted with the Volgrim on that ship, then?"

"Of course. Hundreds of times." Hideki said nonchalantly. I've never been able to establish any meaningful contact with the Founders, but placing some bait for little

Nufaris isn't difficult at all."

Jason nodded.

Then his expression warped.

"Nufaris? Executor Nufaris?!"

Hideki raised an eyebrow. "No. Is there an Executor named Nufaris? I've accessed some secret Volgrim personnel logs and I don't recall seeing that name."

Jason's back became slick with sweat. He suddenly remembered some important information from the future.

"That's right... Nufaris was a low-level Volgrim until the Energy Wars began. He shot up in power and ascended faster than any other Psion in history, possibly even the Second Founder. He became the most powerful Executor, the most feared one of them all. To think he's only a low-level scrub right now! Maybe I could..."

Jason made a silent cutting motion across his neck. Daisy and Hideki got the message.

"If he's going to become such a thorn in humanity's side someday, then taking him out isn't a bad idea." Hideki nodded. "But that will cause extreme effects downstream on the timeline. Nufaris isn't a nobody. He's 'only' a 5th-Level Psion right now, only recently having entered the military. If he dies while watching Earth, it will draw intense scrutiny toward our movements. I'm afraid even you won't be able to hide from the prying eyes of the Executors and the Second Founder if that happens."

Jason's bloodlust cooled. He sobered up, and leaned back in his seat.

"Later, then. He's no threat to us right now. I need to take him out before he reaches the 6th Level, but even for a prodigy like Nufaris, that'll still be hundreds, even thousands of years from now."

Jason remained quiet for a few moments. Then he spoke.

"**Projection.**"

Hideki blinked in surprise as Jason conjured a magical blackboard in the air and began writing. Even now, he had yet to become accustomed to Jason's 'new' Wordsmithing powers.

Jason quickly started writing down several words and bullet points.

MANIFEST ORIGINAL POWERS AND ABILITIES

CONSTRUCT TIME ACCELERATED REALM

REMAIN ICOGNITO: PLAGUE NOT YET A FACTOR, FULL VOLGRIM MILITARY STRUCTURE INTACT

INVESTIGATE VOLGRIM, DETERMINE THREAT LEVELS

EMPOWER HUMANS, REMOVE FLAW

PACIFY DEMONS, PREFERABLY FORM ALLIANCES, BUT EXTERMINATE IF NECESSARY

MAKE PEACE WITH ANGELS IF POSSIBLE, FORM ALLIANCE PREFERABLE, GENOCIDE ACCEPTABLE

He paused after writing these bullets points. A moment later, his eyes shone as he realized something else, then wrote it down.

LOCATE BAHAMUT, RESCUE HER PRISONERS (SAVE PHOEBE!!!) Daisy's heart skipped a beat. "Mom...?"

"She's with Bahamut." Jason said evenly. "She's not... 'my' Phoebe. But I still love her. I have to save her, as soon as possible. Even if our relationship cannot be remade... I... I can't bear to let your mother's younger self accidentally perish. I'll protect her for the rest of her life if that's what it takes."

Daisy's eyes turned misty. She closed them, then looked away, feeling heartbroken by the knowledge she'd never be able to see her 'real' mother again.

Jason steeled his heart. He moved on.

LOCATE BLACK WITCH, DETERMINE CURRENT STATUS

CONSIDER MOVING ENTIRETY OF MARIE'S FUTURE REMNANT OASIS FACILITY TO SECRET DIMENSIONAL SPACE

LOCATE CAMAEL'S CUBE

REBUILD INTERNAL MIND REALM; ESTABLISH NEW 'SMITHY' PROTOCOLS; RETURN BRAIN FUNCTION TO SUPERHUMAN LEVELS

Jason examined his list. It was not in the order he thought most effective, and it still needed additions, but it was a start.

Hideki scratched his head. "What's this about a 'Plague'?"

"I didn't tell you yet?" Jason asked.

Hideki searched his memories. "Not that I recall."

"The Plague is a biological weapon sent to the Milky Way by a different galaxy." Jason explained. "It's like the Borg from Star Trek, but on steroids. It devours life forms, assimilates their powers into itself, and spawns plaguehosts that can jump from world to world. In fact, I should check to see if the Cosmic Realm has already been infected. If so, maybe I can exterminate the Plague early, before it reaches a critical mass."

"...Cosmic Realm?" Hideki asked again, visibly lost. "The future must be more exciting than I imagined if you can keep hitting me with all these exotic new terms."

"I'll tell you about all this stuff later." Jason said. "Let's focus on the big picture. How should I reorder this list in terms of first to last?"

"I want to save mom first." Daisy immediately volunteered. "Before anything else."

"I do too. But we have to be realistic." Jason said. "I'm no threat to the demons right now. If I prematurely take out Bahamut... she has a lot of connections with the demons. I might alert them to my existence. I need to be incognito. Defeat my enemies before they know I'm a threat. The last thing I want is for them to gather the full scope of my powers and find ways to counter me like they did in the future."

Jason grimaced.

"I was young and naïve when I first left that cryopod. I had no idea what my powers could do. I gave all my secrets to Amelia for free, and she gave them to her slave, Satan, who then told the other demons. This time I won't make that mistake. If the demons don't know what my powers are, then I'll continually be able to ambush them."

"Problem." Hideki grunted. "The Illuminati picked you up. Despite how 'impressive' their facility might seem, they're a known asset, and they apprehended you in broad daylight. It's entirely possible, perhaps even likely that the demons already know who you are."

Jason scrunched up his face. "Maybe they do, dad. Maybe they know my face, and they know I'm a Hero. That's frustrating, but it's a loss I can accept. They *won't* know what my powers are. In fact..."

The Wordsmith's eyes suddenly flashed with insight. He glanced at his floating list in the air, and a devious look crossed his face. He scratched a new line at the bottom.

PROJECT 'THE GREAT DECEIVER': MAKE THE DEMONS THINK I'M SOMETHING I'M NOT "Heh heh heh..." Jason chuckled, his eyes turning sinister. "Oh, yeah. I can *barely* contain my excitement."

He rubbed his palms together, and Hideki looked at his son as if he were a ghost. He had no concept of Jason acting this way in any of his previous lives. Jason was always a bit of a dope, somewhat naïve and idyllic, thinking of trying to overcome racism and species-ism and other things of that sort. In several timelines, he'd even proclaimed that he had a 'no killing rule', like *Batman*.

It was utterly ridiculous.

And yet now, the same person who looked like his son seemed entirely alien to Hideki. He couldn't figure out what Jason was thinking.

"The Great Deceiver?" Hideki repeated, visibly confused.

Jason snickered. "You can't figure it out, dad? Come on. You're billions of years old. Think about it."

Unfortunately, even though Hideki was ancient and possessed a mountain of experience, he had also become quite rigid and fond of specific timelines, actions, and other such things. He had lost a lot of his inventiveness over the years, and mostly brute-forced events with his powers.

He sat for a few moments and slowed down time to think about what his son was planning.

"You... you're going to... pretend not to be a Wordsmith?" Hideki eventually asked.

"Something like that." Jason replied. "More specifically, the Illuminati is the only organization that knows 'anything' about my metaphysical abilities, and they've developed an *entirely* wrong impression of who I am and what I can do."

He continued. "Think about it, dad. The Illuminati believe me to be a seer, blessed with the ability to foretell future events. They think I 'downloaded' combat knowledge from experts in the future, or something."

Jason leaned forward and grinned. "So why don't we make sure that's all the demons *think* I can do?"

A light gleamed in Hideki's eye. He finally wrapped his brain around his son's grand plan.

"The Art of War. You know what your enemies can do. They don't know what you can do. That gives you a massive advantage when facing them. You can use this knowledge to slowly turn them upside down, undermine their confidence, and ultimately crush them."

This time, Daisy added her own thoughts. "This won't only work on the demons. It will work on the Volgrim too, dad. If you can act convincingly enough, you might make the Volgrim fear you enough that they hesitate to attack Earth."

Jason nodded his head up and down, becoming visibly pleased by what he was hearing.

"That's exactly my plan. I just need to lean into the 'persona' the Illuminati have handily invented for me, and then I'll be able to manipulate it to my advantage."

Jason looked at his floating list. He added one final entry at the end.

SAVE THE EARTH. CONQUER THE GALAXY. PACIFY THE UNIVERSE. Jason chuckled. "Well. That might be a little ambitious. Let's just focus on one thing at a time."

The trio continued to speak for a while. Eventually, Daisy stood up.

"I have to go, dad."

"Go?" Jason asked, his chest tightening. "Go where? You can stay, honey! You should stay."

Daisy pulled a smartphone out of her pocket. "It's already 10PM in Moscow. It's my bedtime. I have military school tomorrow and the next day, then I have the weekend off. I'd love to stay longer, but I need to keep my grades up."

Jason gave his daughter a bizarre look. "Education is good, honey. But... you know... the fate of the Earth is a bit more important. Are you planning to get a normal job or something? Seems kind of unnecessary."

"I have friends." Daisy simply said. "I have a life, and obligations, dad. I'm so happy to see you're alive, and you remember me, and we can... we can finally talk again. But I still need to live my life. And be honest. Do you really need my involvement for this first part? It's mostly going to be you and grandpa dealing with the future war stuff, right?"

Jason blinked. He looked away, then nodded.

"Oh. Yeah, actually. You're right. I don't need you getting involved for now. Leave this to the grownups. It's better if you take a few years to learn and become more worldly. In

the meantime, if we need you, I can always find you."

Jason stood up from his seat. He took a step toward his daughter, then paused.

"**Create. Create. Link. Adjust.**"

To Daisy's surprise, her father made a pair of simple clamp-type earrings that were flesh colored, blending in perfectly with human skin. He handed one to his daughter, then kept the other for himself.

"I made something similar for your mother once." Jason explained. "These are not as simple as they appear. I can track your location, and you can track mine. We can communicate across any distance, and even if Gressil were to shut off your magical powers, they still function through quantum entanglement. You can always contact me if a terrible situation occurs."

"Hopefully that won't happen." Daisy said.

But even so, she smiled, her cheeks turning slightly pink. She took the earring and cradled it carefully, giving her father a strange look.

In that moment, Jason understood her thoughts.

She'd been separated from him for twelve years.

Twelve birthdays. No father to protect her. No father to love her, lavish gifts on her, or greet her in the morning.

This was the first gift her daddy had given her in recent memory.

Jason couldn't help himself. He teared up. He stepped forward and embraced his daughter, weeping quietly as he once again imagined the terrible life she'd lived without him.

"I'm so sorry, baby girl." Jason whispered. "I won't leave you again. I won't fail you again."

"Dad..." Daisy said softly, her eyes becoming equally misty.

She hugged him back. They embraced for a long while before finally, reluctantly pulling away. They dried their tears and attached their earrings.

"We'll see each other again soon." Daisy promised. "This weekend?"

"Tomorrow, if you want. But this weekend works too." Jason said with a smile.

A moment later, Daisy disappeared. She teleported away, leaving her father and grandfather behind to stare at the empty space where she stood only moments before.

A while later, Hideki Hiro stood up. He slipped on his mask and nodded toward the door.

"Alright. We might as well get started, son. Let me show you what I've been working on under these mountains."

Jason glanced at his long list of future goals. It seemed insurmountable at the moment, but he knew that it was only a matter of time before he started tearing through it, forging a better future for himself, his daughter, and humanity too.

"Yeah." Jason said. "Let's get this party started."

Part 624: The New LEGION

January 15th, 2021. Noon. New York City.

While Jason and his newly rediscovered family reunited with one another, elsewhere on the complete opposite side of the United States, a man in his 60's climbed out of his car in front of a large skyscraper deep in the Manhattan District. As he exited, a valet walked up to him, the young man's eyes glimmering with excitement as he gazed upon the pristine condition 1970's Corvette, colored deep red with pop-up headlights.

The older man barely gave the valet a second glance. He tossed the keys to the young man, then sighed. He wordlessly walked toward the skyscraper's entrance while glancing up at the massive logo of a dollar sign followed by the corporation's name:

Legion.

The name had some ominous connotations, but aside from some unproven claims about funding militant coups in South America, it was about as benign as any other corporation. The front of the building was not to the old man's tastes though. He chuckled as he looked at the gaudy gargoyles mounted on the sides of the building, going up fifty floors high. Every five floors, there was another one, and they were all gold-plated too. Clearly, the owner of the building had some... ostentatious tastes.

The old man shuffled inside, leaning heavily on a cane. He groaned as his knee silently popped, reminding him of just how old he was. Unfortunately, his degenerative neurological condition was worsening, and it had started affecting the function of the rest of his body.

He approached the revolving front door. A bulky young doorman stood outside and smiled as he approached.

"Morning, sir. I hope you're having a pleasant day."

The old man grunted. "I wish I was."

No more words were exchanged. He stepped into the revolving door, then stepped out, arriving inside the building's lobby. The warm orange lights overhead gave the entryway a classy feeling. Luxurious seats were lined up to the right, outside the offices for the low-

level managers and ordinary plebs. The old man headed left instead, walking over to a counter with a beautiful receptionist. She smiled at him as he approached.

"Good morning, sir. How can I help you today?"

He smiled back, but the expression lacked sincerity. "I'm here to see Mark."

The woman blinked twice. "The CEO? Do you have an appointment?"

"Just tell him it's Seymour." The old man said. "He'll know."

The young woman hesitated, but then she reached for a phone and dialed a number.

"...Hi, Lily. Yes, I have a man here, says his name is 'Seymour'. He wants to meet with- oh? Oh, excellent. I'll have someone escort him up."

She quickly hung up the phone and smiled again. "If you'll wait a moment, we'll have someone guide you up to his office."

"No need." Seymour said. "I know the way."

He shuffled over to the elevator, stepped inside, then fell silent as the door closed. There were already a handful of people inside, all of them staring at their smartphones. Seymour stood in the corner and appraised them, but said nothing. He'd grown used to seeing young folks glued to their phones over the years. He felt the fall of social interaction was unfortunate a decade ago, but these days he liked it more when he wasn't being bothered by unnecessary chatter with random nobodies.

The people on the elevator stepped off and on as the elevator advanced to the topmost floor. Soon, Seymour was the last person riding it. This was the executive floor after all, and few people had a good reason to come here.

When the elevator doors opened, Seymour slowly stepped out and made his way out into the main hall, where he found three different secretaries seated at different desks. However, only one desk was positioned just outside the CEO's main office. He recognized this particular position was always owned by the head secretary.

As he walked over, Seymour sized up the pretty black-haired woman seated in the head secretary's seat. Unfortunately, he didn't recognize her. Mark had a habit of switching out his secretaries every few years. He liked them to be as young and beautiful as possible. Rumors had it he slept with them, but those were of course unproven, and his wife probably wouldn't approve.

"Mister Madrid. Thank you for paying us a visit today." The lead secretary volunteered as he approached. "You can walk right in. Mark is waiting for you."

Seymour nodded at her. She was a real bombshell alright, easily a ten out of ten. Over the course of his life, he'd seen so many ethereal beauties that he'd grown a bit bored by them. They all blended together in a way, especially the ones Mark liked to keep around.

Just as Seymour was drawing closer to the door, it opened up, and a five-foot-tall man stepped out, his figure much shorter than Seymour's. He wore a surprisingly ostentatious suit that was white with black stars embroidered all over it. Many had called Mark an oddball for his taste in clothing, but he always laughed those words off. They didn't affect his self-esteem in the slightest. He had the bearings of a man far above others of his kind, making it so mere words rolled right off his back.

"Seymour!" Mark exclaimed. "Hey hey, buddy! Come on in! I didn't know you were dropping by!"

"Sorry for the surprise visit." Seymour said, as he shuffled over and extended his hand. "I didn't expect I'd be... still out and about."

The two men shook hands, but Mark went a step further and lightly clapped his taller comrade on the back, laughing as he did. "Man, you've got the cane and everything! You're really trying to lean into the Warren Buffet look, huh? Classy!"

He glanced at his secretary. "Thanks for letting him in, Lily."

"No problem, Mister Hercule." Lily replied with a smile.

Mark Hercule closed the door, and he and Seymour wandered over to a pleasant little seating area with couches and a low table.

"Go on, take a seat, take a load off." Mark said, as he touched his well-maintained facial hair. "Something to drink?"

"The doctor says alcohol is bad for me." Seymour said, grunting as he bent at the knees and gently lowered his butt onto the nearest couch. "But if you have anything that can make this arthritis hurt just a little bit less..."

"Sure, sure. I've just the thing." Mark said, nodding.

While Mark pulled out a bottle of some hundred year old wine and a couple of glasses, Seymour glanced around his office. It was just as gaudy as the rest of the building. He had various animal heads mounted on the walls, a golden set of golf clubs haphazardly leaned

against his desk, even a golden fiddle mounted on the wall. If there was one thing Mark liked, it was gold. He couldn't help but deck out everything in gold plating and trim.

Seymour's eyes momentarily fell on a wooden cabinet on the other side of the room. Inside it were, of all things, martial arts trophies. Apparently, Mark had been quite a fighter when he was younger.

"So, what's been happening?" Mark asked as he walked over and held out a glass of wine. Seymour accepted it and took a few sips as Mark sat down across from him. "Word on the grapevine has it you were volunteering for some medical procedure. That go well?"

"Not exactly." Seymour grunted. "Damn. It still pisses me off. There I was over at Cryotek labs. Some kid walks in, all dazed and confused, looking like he stumbled out of a fairy tale. He'd actually volunteered to be cryogenically frozen. Can you believe it? Anyway, I felt some pity for him, so I threw him a bone, said I'd pay for him to bail out of the procedure. But then the damnedest thing happened."

Seymour shook his head wryly. "The feds burst in, grabbed the kid, and took him away! Turns out he was a criminal of some sort. Couldn't even find anything about it in the paper. Must have been one of those low-key operations. Anyway, they shut down Cryotek for the next week or so, said it was due to security concerns."

Mark nodded. His forehead creased in concern. "Cryotek, huh? Isn't that the cryogenic lab that popped up a few years? What were you doing there?"

Seymour sipped his wine. He looked away.

"Guess."

A moment of tense silence followed. Mark held his wine glass, but he didn't take a sip. He merely stared at Seymour with a complicated expression.

"Oh. You're getting old, huh? I didn't realize things had become that bad."

"I'm getting old? You are too." Seymour scoffed. "You're just better at hiding it. What's your secret anyway? You don't look a day over thirty."

Mark chuckled. "What can I say? I signed a contract with the Devil. In exchange for eternal youth and all the women I'd ever want, he'd take my soul. That's why I got into corporate merging. There's no soul in this business anyway!"

"Yeah yeah, what a jokester." Seymour grunted.

The two men continued to talk for a while. Eventually, Seymour broached the subject he'd been intending to since he arrived.

"Say, uh, Mark? Can you help an old friend out?"

"Buddy! Buddy, you don't even have to ask, pal. State your request!" Mark exclaimed.

"It's Cryotek." Seymour explained. "I can probably continue on for a couple of weeks, but... I want to enter cryostasis as soon as possible. The sooner I enter, the more time I'll have after exiting stasis in the future to cure my disease. My hope is that I'll be able to regain a few more years, enjoy what little I can of my mortality before..."

He trailed off, leaving the implication hanging in the air.

Mark fell silent. He massaged his hair chin and chewed his lower lip.

"I don't have any pull with Cryotek, unfortunately. I might be able to start some sort of acquisition proceedings, but that'd be expensive, and it'd take time if we went through the proper channels. Even if I sped things up just for you, we're still talking at least a week of waiting..."

Seymour's expression fell. He lowered his eyes. "Yeah. I suppose I was asking too much."

"Whoa, whoa whoa!" Mark said. "Now, come on, buddy. I'm not gonna leave an old friend out in the rain. Look pal, I know this place, alright? Specializes in 'faith healing'. It's real exclusive, top shelf stuff. Maybe I can have one of the girls there take a look, eh? I bet she could at least relieve your pain a bit."

"Faith healing?" Seymour asked, visibly skeptical. "That sounds like..."

"A bunch of hogwash, right?" Mark retorted, before gesturing to himself. "I use it all the time, and look at me!"

Seymour blinked. Mark had a point. He was in his sixties, but he still looked thirty. Whatever Mark was doing, it clearly worked.

"Faith healing, huh?" Seymour grunted, massaging his chin. "It's worth a shot, I suppose."

"Great!" Mark chirped. "I'll draw you up a contract later, get you signed up for the good stuff. You'll have to sign an NDA, but a guy like you knows how to keep his trap shut, right? I only tell my good friends about this place, so I'm stickin' my neck out for ya."

"I understand." Seymour said, feeling a little warmer inside. It was always nice to have friends in high places. "At this point, even a little pain relief would go a long way. I owe you, Mark."

"Hey, you don't owe me jack." Mark laughed. "Remember? You helped push through that merger a few years back. Your word had a lot of pull, and Mark Hercule always remembers his friends."

"It was a small matter, small, no big deal at all." Seymour said politely.

The two men continued to talk for over an hour. Eventually, Seymour shakily stood up to leave.

"Well hey, pal, thanks for dropping by." Mark said, as he embraced Seymour in a hug. "Always great to see an old friend. Just chat with Lily and she'll give you the deets."

"Absolutely. Thank you, Mark. Thank you. I truly appreciate everything." Seymour said, as he pulled away.

A minute later, Seymour strode out the door, leaving Mark alone in his office.

Several minutes passed.

Mark remained standing in place, gazing at the cabinet full of martial arts trophies he'd earned some fifty years earlier. He silently thought to himself about several matters.

Eventually, he walked over and opened his door.

"Lily. My office, please."

His secretary stood up. She adjusted her glasses, and the other two secretaries sneaked jealous peeks at her as Mark led her into his office. After the door closed, the two of them huffed silently. Why was it always Lily who got all the good times? When would it be their turn?

It was a well-known fact that Mark always rotated new women from outside the company to be his Head Secretary, but he had one important rule. He would always address these new girls by the name 'Lily', no matter what their real name was.

As Lily stepped into the office, and closed the door, she faced Mark for a moment.

"Problem?" Lily asked.

"Don't know. Maybe. Smells like something nasty." Mark said, his jovial smile gone. He and Lily faced one another for a few moments.

"Seymour mentioned something interesting." Mark continued. "Said there was a kid who got nabbed over at Cryotek. Said it was the feds. Mind having Ose look into it? She's good with that computer shit, right?"

Lily shrugged. Her appearance abruptly began to change as she morphed her body and clothes, turning her skin red, and her prim and proper secretary outfit into a *much* tighter, sexier, and more revealing succubus outfit. Her massive breasts were barely even hidden behind the two thin strips of cloth that moved down from her neck to her waist.

Lily was in fact Belial, the Emperor of Lust. As for the man in front of her...

"Is that an *order*, dear?" Belial asked playfully, leaning down to wink at him.

Mark chuckled. He fiddled with a ring on his finger, and after a moment, his skin turned blood-red, horns materialized on his head, and his eyes turned demonic.

He was actually Satan the Devil, hidden in human form.

"Ain't no order, babe." Satan said. "I just wanna know what's going on over in the west. In fact... why don't you take a week or two off. Have Ose look into the computer stuff, but you go there, boots on the ground, see what you can sniff up. This has a secret society's fingerprints all over it."

Belial crinkled her nose. "The Illuminati is based in Oregon. The Templar Knights have a base in California. Could be either one of them."

"Could be pigeons too." Satan muttered. "Always poking around, hiding among the humans better than we do. Doesn't match the MO, though. They wouldn't drive a van."

After a few more minutes of brainstorming, they finished up their business.

"Seymour could use a looking-at." Satan said. "Seems he has some sort of degenerative neurological disorder infecting his brain. Think you can look into it? I'm gonna have him drop by the Institute later tomorrow."

"Do you want me to deal with Seymour or the kid in the west first?" Belial asked.

"Seymour. It'd be a shame to lose a smart guy like him. He's got connections with some of the top bankers." Satan explained. "The kid probably isn't anyone important. I just wanna make sure."

Belial batted her eyes. "Well, alright. It's gonna be lonely, leaving you behind for a week or two..."

"Haha, then why don't you c'mere and gimme some sugar?" Satan grinned, as he reached around and grabbed her ass.

Minutes later, the two of them were on the couch, making loud noises that drew the attention of the two secretaries outside. The two young women blushed as they heard the somewhat obnoxiously loud moans coming from within Mister Hercule's office, but they didn't dare to stand up and take a look. There were cameras in the secretary's area anyway.

An hour later, the door opened up, and Lily exited, looking no different than before.

"Dana, I'll be taking a business trip for the next week or two. You'll be in charge while I'm gone."

Dana's eyes lit up. This was her chance! With Lily gone, she might actually have a shot at getting in Mister Hercule's good graces.

"Of course." Dana said, keeping her excitement muted. "Enjoy your trip, Lily."

Belial narrowed her eyes. She could easily smell the young woman's interest in her husband, but it didn't really matter. Satan was more than enough man to handle dozens of side pieces. None of them would ever stack up to his true love.

Without another word, Belial strode out of the office and took the elevator downstairs.

Soon, she would be investigating the seemingly unimportant happening on the west coast. Whatever it might be, she wasn't entirely certain. But she believed it could be at least a little significant.

After she left, Satan walked around his office and buttoned his pants back up. He grabbed a towel and dabbed the sweat off his face, feeling re-energized after a raucous love-making session with his wife. Even after thousands of years, their flame never went out. She was just as good of a lay as during the Ancient Era. Better, even. She had far more experience than the limpid, dead fish who thought they could compete. Satan sometimes tried tasting human women, but they always bored him beyond belief. They were just too inexperienced to be any fun. The two secretaries outside had no idea he'd judged them long ago and found them lacking.

By comparison, his relationship with Belial was like a fine wine. They always found new ways to surprise one another, no matter how much time passed.

"Seymour..." Satan said, with a long sigh. He motioned with his hands, and a magical contract appeared in the air. He stared at it for a moment before rapidly writing down hundreds of words, the text so small few could properly read it, let alone an old man with bad vision like Seymour.

"Shame." Satan said, shaking his head. "Time really flies, doesn't it? You meet an interesting human, and he dies not long after. Some things just never change."

A male voice inside Satan's head spoke. [Verily, the lives of mortals art fleeting like the wind. Thou mustn't let thyself grow attached.]

"Yeah. You said it, Hades." Satan grunted, as he gazed at the finalized contract in his grasp. "It's too bad. At least I'll get to keep him with me, rather than letting him fall into the hands of those pigeons."

His magical contracts gave Satan one possible way of stealing the souls of other creatures before they could enter the Lazarus Tower, located at the heart of Heaven. The demons knew about it, but attacking a place enveloped by so many angels was suicide.

Still, Satan had a plan. Someday, he would steal the Tower's power for himself. At that time, he'd integrate it into his new Realm and make an unholy land for all of demonkind to flourish!

But that was still some time in the future. Satan wasn't ready to commit too many demons to an assault that would guarantee millions, even billions of their deaths.

There was still so much work he had to do...

Satan meandered over to his giant office window. He stood there, holding a glass of vodka, gazing out at all the busy little humans moving around, living their boring and mundane lives.

"Do you smell that, Hades? Smells like big change. Things have been quiet. Too quiet. It's been decades since the humans lost their Trueborn. This stalemate can't go on forever."

A vicious smile spread across the interior of Satan's Mind Realm. The former archangel known as Samael grinned hideously.

[My brother shalt *pay* for what he's done. The angels shalt fall. The demons will rise. The beginning of a new era shalt follow, god-willing.]

Satan sipped his vodka.

"Too bad I don't believe in *gods*."

Part 625: Humanity's Pillars

January 15th, 2021. 1PM. Boise National Forest, Idaho.

Jason followed his father, Hideki. The two of them traveled over to the entrance leading into the underground mountain that would someday become Marie Becker's Remnant Oasis. Jason chuckled quietly to himself, knowing humanity's future safehouse was a metaphorical stone's throw from where he grew up. Life was full of surprises.

The two Heroes hopped in the shuttle at the top of the entrance and zipped deep down into the shaft leading under the mountain. Jason looked around as they drove and marveled at the sheer size of the tunnel.

"We need to be able to move large vehicles, spacecraft, salvage, and construction materials quickly over the next few decades." Hideki explained. "This shaft might seem like a huge vulnerability when the Earth is destroyed, but I've constructed it out of extremely durable materials. I also have several suppliers lined up to move alien materials over once those become available during the Energy Wars. At its peak, the Remnant Oasis should become reinforced enough to survive all but the most devastating of Volgrim attacks."

Jason fell silent for a moment.

"Dad, how does the Earth...?"

He trailed off, glancing at his father out of the corner of his eye. His stomach tightened.

"I don't know." Hideki said quietly. "I've survived past the end of the Energy Wars several times. But the only way to do that was by taking refuge inside the Labyrinth or jumping into a spaceship and escaping before the Volgrim completed their encirclement. All I know is that the Volgrim possess multiple superweapons, including a material called 'trifrancium' which is capable of completely obliterating worlds the size of Earth. Luckily, they used a different superweapon during the Energy Wars. It 'merely' glassed the planet's surface, along with about a mile of Earth's crust. People living deep underground were able to survive the immediate aftermath, though not for long. The evaporation of Earth's oxygen and food supply ensured only the most diehard preppers lived beyond the first year. The rest died within ten."

"Except for Marie." Jason pointed out.

"Yes. Except for Marie." Hideki replied softly.

The shuttle arrived at the bottom of the shaft, but Hideki didn't immediately disembark. He sat there for a minute, his expression downcast.

"We have a chance, son. A chance to save the Earth. But it won't be easy. Even if your powers are truly formidable, you still died in the future to Founder Dosena. You also described a future war with the Kolvaxians that ate up 99% of the Volgrim's energy. We will not be fighting them under such ideal conditions. The Volgrim are, as of right now, the absolute rulers of our galaxy. If they even get a whiff of humanity's power and fear us just the littlest bit, the power they can bring down upon us will make the fall of Maiura look like child's play. I've hacked their systems many times, and even I couldn't uncover their most frightening secrets."

Hideki looked at his son with eyes full of sadness.

"I've been trying for so long, Jason. I've been trying to win this war. I lost all hope eons ago. I assumed winning wasn't possible. Even now, the slender hope you've reignited in my heart is still... almost nothing. I fear you might be overestimating your capabilities, and this will all be for nothing."

Jason smiled. He squeezed his dad's shoulder reassuringly.

"Dad. You can't think like that anymore. I'm not the same flippant, useless boy you raised. I'm a seasoned man, hundreds of years old at this point. I might still be a baby compared to you, but I'm not held back by the follies and insecurities of youth. We *will* win. As long as we believe in the power of humanity, *nothing* will stop us."

Jason stepped out of the shuttle and took a deep breath.

"Because that's humanity's greatest strength. We hold the collective power of belief. So long as our willpower is clad in steel, we will not allow our alien tyrants to crush us."

Hideki remained seated for a moment. He looked at his son's back, and in his heart, he felt that Jason truly was different now.

The two of them were both broken men. Men who had lost their wives. Men who had given in to anguish.

But Jason had already set his own pain aside. The reappearance of his little girl gave him a new lease on life.

As a husband and a father, Jason could never again allow himself to be struck down by his foes.

So much was riding on him.

He had to become *unbreakable*.

Jason turned to look at his father. "Well? Let's get moving. Time waits for no man."

Hideki sobered up. He nodded, then stepped out of the shuttle.

"Let's see if this early Remnant Oasis gives you any ideas, son."

Jason had already seen the Remnant Oasis a couple of times when visiting it in the future. Thus, he was not too surprised to see that the one presented to him by his father appeared far more primitive and underdeveloped. The internal space was nowhere near as deep as the one he observed in the future, perhaps only stretching a half mile from the ceiling to the lowest level below. However, Jason was able to observe lots of in-between levels containing prototype weapons and machines that surprised him. He didn't see them when he visited Marie in the future.

"I first started work on this project... fifteen years ago." Hideki explained, as they stood at a railing on the top level and looked down at the colossal complex below. "Was it fifteen? I have trouble keeping track of standard temporal time. Anyway, the biggest thing that always slows down the construction of this complex is my need for secrecy. Moving vast amounts of machinery around requires manpower. Manpower means people. People mean potential leaks. Leaks mean I could inadvertently draw the attention of outsiders. And *that* is the thing I have to avoid most."

Hideki made a sweeping gesture with his hands. "This temporal timeline finished functional construction six years ago. Since then, I've moved in specialists whose loyalties I can be assured of, having interacted with them thousands of times. The problem comes later, when we need to build more impressive robots and weapons. I can't rely on scaling laws to simply build construction robots that build other robots. Earth doesn't have time. That means the next ten years are a critical period where I have to move quickly but carefully when adding additional manpower."

Jason listened. He remained silent, assessing his father's plans while surreptitiously thinking about all the ways his unique power could enhance and speed them up.

Hideki pointed toward the 7th floor. There, a handful of men and women were constructing a set of combat armor that looked far beyond anything Jason would expect to see on Earth in this year. The armor was colored white and used plastic molding, but Jason observed all sorts of complicated tubules leading into the armor, a mask to filter out environmental toxins, and some sort of integrated weaponry on the right and left wrists he couldn't quite make out from this distance.

"Thanks to Solomon's Seed, I am able to iterate and improve on existing prototypes by bringing schematics of future weapons to the scientists of this era. Unfortunately, there are terrible diminishing returns. Once weapons become too advanced, the inventors and engineers here will spend more time trying to wrap their brains around esoteric future weaponry principles rather than updating and improving them further. Each time they complete a prototype and I rewind, the next iteration takes longer and longer until we eventually reach a standstill."

Hideki balled his fist in frustration. "I tried building robots myself that could understand future tech, but I ran into different problems. Until the creation of UMI, the AI of this era is too primitive to innovate and create new technological paradigms. And why wouldn't it be? Even the Technopaths have to use their own creativity to iterate Volgrim technology. Unless they create an Alpha or Omega Core Synthmind, which they *never* will, they can only rely on the efforts of biological creativity."

Jason nodded. "That's why you were planning to conclude your rewinding and finalize all your plans. You hit an impassable bottleneck. If you could continue iterating on the technological principles from the future, you might eventually out-scale the Volgrim and create weapons that would force them to bend the knee."

"Yeah. Pretty much."

Cat Mask looked around. He gestured for Jason to follow, and the two of them took a lift down to the 13th floor, where they arrived at a work bay devoid of personnel. There, a half completed robot of some sort was scattered across multiple tables. Jason couldn't comprehend what its final form would look like, since it was at most thirty percent complete, but it was definitely going to be huge, over twenty feet tall once complete.

"Demonbusters." Hideki grunted, gesturing to the robot. "Large. Powerful. But impractical. I've tried multiple times to finish construction of this robot, but I failed. The schematics are incomplete. In theory, the machine will be powerful enough to go one-on-

one with Demon Emperors and have a shot at winning, but in practice, it always ends up too slow and cumbersome. The power system runs out of juice within less than an hour, making it useless for attrition warfare against foes like Satan, and while the main cannon can obliterate the weaker-bodied Dukes and Emperors, it's slow to fire and easy to dodge."

Jason nodded. He walked over to the incomplete robot, then reached toward a random part before glancing at his father.

"You mind?"

"Have at it." Hideki said, clearly not expecting much. "The worst you'll do is destroy something. It's useless as-is right now."

Jason nodded. He picked up some sort of cylinder, then spoke a Word of Power.

"**Analyze.**"

Instantly, a three-dimensional schematic appeared inside his Mind Realm. Without Fiona to analyze it, or even his internal supercomputers, Jason could only attempt a cursory examination.

Words scrolled through his mind.

Component Name: Teraforce Energy Capacitor

Functionality: Primary power storage and distribution unit for the Demonbuster combat system.

Description: Cylindrical quantum-state energy storage device utilizing compressed dimensional pockets to contain and stabilize power loads exceeding conventional physical limitations. Advanced internal circuitry ensures rapid discharge capabilities during combat while maintaining structural integrity under extreme stress conditions.

Strengths: Capable of powering the main cannon with sufficient output to obliterate lesser demonic entities. Features emergency power rerouting systems that automatically prioritize defensive shields during critical failures.

Limitations: Inefficient energy retention results in significant power bleed during standby operations, reducing effective combat time to under one hour. Quantum stabilization field requires constant maintenance by internal systems, consuming 18% of stored power merely to maintain operational status.

"Hmm." Jason grunted, while his father stared wordlessly from the side.

Jason set the component down. He picked up a simple looking rod at the side, its functionality not obvious at a glance.

"**Analyze.**" Jason said again.

More words appeared in his mind.

Component Name: Neural Interface Linkage Rod

Functionality: Basic connection component that transmits control signals between the pilot interface and primary command modules.

Description: Standard titanium-alloy rod with embedded fiber-optic pathways and minimal signal processing capabilities. Serves as a simple but essential connection point in the Demonbuster's neural response system.

Strengths: Durable construction resistant to electromagnetic interference. Easily replaceable with minimal technical knowledge required.

Limitations: Possesses no specialized functions beyond signal transmission. Vulnerable to physical damage at connection points. Cannot filter or enhance pilot commands, merely relays them unchanged to downstream systems.

Jason massaged his chin as he grunted once again. "Hmmm....."

Hideki raised an eyebrow. From his perspective, his son seemed to be simply picking up parts, speaking a single word, then humming to himself. Even so, Hideki remained silent. He would rather just let Jason do his thing until he either gave up or found something interesting. This would be a good test of his son's new abilities.

Jason walked over to the incomplete head of the robot.

"So is this a robot, or is it an exosuit for a human to pilot?" Jason asked.

"We couldn't decide." Hideki explained. "Some of my guys thought it was too slow to adapt to various demons without a pilot inside, but adding a pilot meant increasing the internal space which only slowed it down more. We've gone through multiple iterations without success."

Jason nodded. He touched the head of the robot, then spoke another Word of Power.

"**Analyze.**"

Even more words appeared in his mind.

Component Name: Cerebral Command Core

Functionality: Primary sensory processing and tactical decision hub for the Demonbuster combat system.

Description: Reinforced neuro-mimetic substrate housed within a titanium-adamantite alloy shell. Contains advanced threat assessment algorithms, sensor array integration nodes, and combat protocol matrices designed specifically for demonic entity classification. Utilizes quantum-parallel processing to manage simultaneous defensive and offensive operations.

Strengths: Capable of analyzing demonic energy signatures and predicting attack patterns with 78.3% accuracy. Contains specialized shielding against psychic interference and memetic corruption attempts by higher-tier demonic entities. Can operate semi-autonomously if pilot connection is severed.

Limitations: Processing architecture prioritizes combat calculations over mobility management, contributing to the unit's sluggish response time. Consumes 23% of main power supply when operating at full capacity. Neural mapping system requires extensive calibration with each pilot, creating a 17-minute vulnerability window during initialization sequence. Heat dissipation insufficient during extended engagement scenarios.

Jason scratched his head. This robot's entire concept was a complete mess. It couldn't decide whether it was a robot or a suit for humans to pilot. It had so many inefficiencies it was borderline useless. As cool as it seemed like it would be in theory, fixing its problems would be just as much work as building an entirely new device.

Still, the robot's basic design gave Jason pause. It did sound badass and terrifying. It could become a beacon of fear among the demons, forcing them to pull back when they saw it appear. Since it was potentially a pure robot, it might not need a human pilot, and that would mean it could be deployed all across the Earth, allowing it to respond to multiple threats. On the other hand, if it were designed for human pilots, maybe the threshold for piloting requirements could lower enough that it could turn humans into pseudo-Hero-level powerhouses. This would provide a major boon in the later stages of the Energy Wars.

"Thoughts?" Hideki finally asked, after seeing his son adopt a contemplative expression.

"There's definitely something here." Jason said. "I need to sleep on it before I draw any conclusions. Right now, you're certainly correct about the whole design being a mishmash of bullshit. It needs streamlining, revisions, and a lot of other stuff I don't currently have the time to do."

Seeing Hideki's face fall, Jason smirked.

"Don't worry, Dad. I didn't say this wasn't salvageable. With a bit of elbow grease, and a *lot* of cheating with my Wordsmithing, I could probably turn this into quite an effective battlefield terror. Can you imagine the look on the demon's faces when they see a hulking 20-foot-tall monstrosity charging at them without stopping? I bet even some of the Emperors might pee their pants."

"That's what I intended," Hideki replied, "but I'm just not sure if you can build this better, son. Even if I rewind time and give you schematics you've worked on, it would just hit the same limitations of scaling all my other tech has."

Jason waved his father's concerns away. "Don't you worry about that. I think the amount of rewinding you'll need to do will be a *lot* less than you initially expect. After all, we don't have ten, twenty, or even just thirty years before the Energy Wars reach their conclusion."

Jason's smirk deepened.

"We have hundreds- no, *thousands* of years. Once I remake my time-accelerated realm and start really getting to work, you're gonna see some crazy shit start to happen."

Hideki nodded slowly. He wasn't entirely convinced. Even if his son was powerful, how much of a difference could a mortal Hero make compared to the cosmic horrors lurking within the Volgrim Empire? At the most, Hideki felt that making a secret realm for the humans to hide in would preserve humanity's strength better than fighting a fruitless war against the Volgrim.

Jason sensed his father's hopelessness. Even so, he maintained his optimism.

Jason already knew some of what he could do. He lacked time in the future. He only had a little more than 6 months in realspace to advance his agenda, and that granted him several hundred years in Chrona. Unfortunately, he was not able to avoid the fate that befell Maiura, then Hope, then himself, then Tarus II.

If he only had more time, he might have been able to save everyone.

But now, he did have time. He could change things, provided he acted in as efficient a manner as possible.

Jason's mind whirred like a creaky rusted machine. He wasn't used to thinking without his cerebral supercomputer assisting him, and it frustrated him how much slower he felt without it.

Should I recreate Chrona first? Or should I rebuild my supercomputer? Or should I find Phoebe, then enlist her help? But she wasn't a technological genius until she came into contact with Solomon, and I don't trust that old fucker as far as I can throw his crown. I'm definitely not putting him on her head this time. In fact, I don't want to involve my past wife unless absolutely necessary. It's fine if she stays out of this war. It's my war to fight.

Jason paced back and forth silently while Hideki crossed his arms and watched. It was still a novel sight for him, seeing his son actually using his brain. He wasn't sure how he felt about it.

It has to be Chrona first. I need time more than anything. But since I don't have my cerebral supercomputer, I won't be able to optimize things nearly as easily as I did when I made Chrona with Fiona's help. But building the supercomputer won't be easy either, since she was critical in optimizing it. Damn! It's a catch-22!

Jason suddenly paused. He looked off into the distance.

I'm going about this all the wrong way. Phoebe, Fiona, Rebecca, and Marie are not the only geniuses I know. I can't rely on Solomon, but what about Mad Madam Mildred? She might be a little weird, but she was Marie's ally in the future. Can I trust her?

He decided to seek a second opinion. "Dad, is Madam Mildred trustworthy?"

Hideki blinked. "Why do you ask? She works for the Illuminati. Those people are a bunch of crazy human supremacists."

"Maybe so, but she helped me a lot in the future." Jason explained. "I need brainpower. I can't trust Solomon, but I never had any reason to dislike Mildred. Maybe the Mildred of the past is a different person, but if she can help me reconstruct my cerebral supercomputer and my time-accelerated realm, then I think allying with her

might be worth it. Jepthath's power will also be extremely useful against our future enemies."

Hideki scrunched up his face. This time, it was him who began to pace back and forth as a debate raged in his head no less fiery than Jason's.

"Mildred... Jepthath... can we trust them? Ah, but there were those major incidents... still, they might not happen in this timeline. Things are different- and there's Jason's influence too. Plus he spoke with them in the future, so maybe they're not totally irredeemable. Hmm. Hmm..."

Like father, like son. Hideki paced around until he came to a decision and stopped.

"Allying with Mildred, huh? It's worth a shot. But she *will* read your mind. She'll know everything about the future. If you're not absolutely certain you can trust her, you should explore other avenues."

Jason shook his head. "I'm certain. Dad, we need allies. Humanity's former Heroes are rock-solid, in my book. Well, maybe not all of them, but enough of them. Solomon is an old schemer I can't trust, same for Raphael, but I don't think Mildred is as vile as them. It's not as if I can't understand her hatred for demons. They hurt me too..."

Jason gestured to the Demonbuster. "Besides. We're gonna need help with all these other projects. I'm willing to explore all avenues. If Mildred betrays us, you can just rewind time and warn me not to trust her."

Hideki nodded slowly. At that moment, his body vibrated, and a look of exhaustion took him. He fell to his knees and grimaced.

"God! Holy shit... oh lord, Jason..."

Jason frowned. He'd come to understand that his dad's 'vibration' indicated he had just rewound time. But Cat Mask's reaction this time was extremely bizarre.

"Did something happen?" Jason asked.

"Not exactly." Cat Mask grimaced, shakily rising back to a standing position. Sweat dripped from his forehead. "I just... whoo.... I just rewound time. It was awful! My power has changed. There's a barrier now. It's slowing me down!"

"Slowing you down?" Jason asked.

"Yes."

Hideki walked over and sat at a table. His eyes were bloodshot. He hung his head and breathed heavily.

"I just came back from a day in the future. It was only *one* day, Jason. We went to visit Mildred. On the way there, something attacked our quad-copter. A demon who threw fireballs from the forest and nearly killed us. I rewound time to try and change things, but... god!"

He wiped his forehead.

"It used to be that when I rewound time, I could rewind even several years and it would only feel like it took me a minute to do so. I could control my *perception* of time. But that isn't the case anymore. A minute of rewound time takes me a minute of perception. A day takes me a day. Don't you see, Jason? If I want to rewind a day into the past, I have to actually rewind one second at a time, slowly, bit by bit... it's AGONY!!"

Jason's heart turned cold.

"But, dad, you're a patient guy... right?"

"Man, FUCK patience!" Hideki snapped. "You don't get it, son. It's like watching a movie in reverse. I can't DO anything when I rewind. I just feel everything slowly, *slowly* moving backward. I feel my mouth move, my body being puppeteered... it wasn't noticeable before you regained your future memories and screwed up the timeline, because all of that happened practically in an instant. But now?! It's unbearable!"

Cat Mask grabbed the sides of his head.

"I don't WANT to rewind time if I have to endure this torture, Jason! What if we really screw things up at the end of the Energy Wars? What if I have to rewind thirty years, or worse, what if I have to re-experience thousands of years in New Chrona?! I might kill myself, son! I really might do it!!"

Jason fell silent. This was outside his expectations.

He knew his father couldn't rewind to a point before he regained his memories. But he didn't expect that the very act of rewinding had become an experience worse than torture to him.

That meant he couldn't count on Hideki rewinding unless it was only a short jaunt into the past. He had to rely on getting things done right this one time, during this singular timeline.

It changed how he wanted to proceed...

...But not by *that* much.

"I understand." Jason said quietly. "Then, dad, don't rewind. Let things play out. Unless we're about to die, just hold off. Leave it to me. I'm nothing if not adaptable."

"That demon saw us leaving the mountain." Hideki explained. "That could mean he'd learn of my hidden base. All my years of preparation would go up in smoke."

Jason shrugged. "Eh, then let him see. We'll adapt and overcome. I'm going to move the entire base to Chrona anyway, remember? The demons won't be able to find it once I finish the transference. Nothing has changed. My plan is set."

Hideki nodded. He looked at his son with different eyes from only a 'few minutes' ago. Seeing his son change plans made him feel strange in his stomach.

For years, it had been Hideki who counted himself as humanity's pillar. But now... it was his son who was taking up that mantle.

Maybe, just maybe, Jason might even succeed.

"Alright." Hideki said quietly. "We'll do it your way then, son."

Part 626: Dance Dance Illuminati

January 16th, 2021. 8AM. Illuminati Haven.

Claire Rothschild sat in front of a series of computer monitors, gazing with cold eyes at recordings of a major event from two days previous. In those recordings, a mysterious masked figure casually knocked out a few security guards, walked into the base, strolled past every possible obstruction in his path, typed in a long and complex code to one particular door, and captured the Trueborn Hero without issue. He wielded a strange device that knocked out the guards with no trouble, and made an absolute mockery of the Illuminati in the process.

Dozens of files sat on the table in front of Claire, many of them opened, showing case reports dating back fifteen years. They briefly described similar events that took place all across Earth, but never seemed relevant to anyone in power until they happened to the Illuminati itself.

Behind Claire, another dark-skinned woman stood. Wearing a white suit with a lapel bearing the insignia of the Illuminati, she not only looked prim and proper, but extremely intimidating today. She tapped her feet and looked at the back of Claire's head with cold, focused eyes.

"I'm still waiting for an explanation, Claire."

"Victoria..." Claire said softly, feeling the breath sucked out of her lungs. "I did explain..."

"No. You gave me excuses. The Trueborn Hero was taken from us. Snatched from the jaws of one of the most secure bases on the West Coast. You really expect me to believe your people are so incompetent that a single man can walk in here, nab our most important asset, and walk out? And why did it take you thirty minutes to even figure out what happened after the fact?"

Claire rubbed her eyes. She had been asleep at the time, and was woken up by a confused assistant wondering why she had issued a order to retrieve the Hero, only to apparently go right back to bed. The truth was, it wasn't Claire who issued that order. It was someone who perfectly mimicked her voice.

"We know it wasn't Belial." Claire explained for the third time. "Nobody could have anticipated-"

"Excuses!" Victoria shouted, slamming her fist on the table. "This unknown intruder somehow disappeared into the fucking woods without a whiff of a fart! How did he get away? Can you even tell me THAT much, you incompetent dolt?!"

Nominally, Victoria and Claire were cousins, albeit distant ones. In terms of political power though, Victoria was a member of the main family branch, while Claire was a thinner-blooded descendant of Jepthath. Victoria held all the cards, while Claire could only defend herself.

"Our best guess is this individual named 'Cat Mask.'" Claire said, heaving a heavy sigh. "We don't have any pictures, but he matches a few descriptions based on testimony from people who caught a glimpse of him. Some say he's the world's greatest assassin. He kills targets from miles away, using only a single shot to do so. He's responsible for the assassination of several world leaders over the years."

"And apparently he's also an infiltration master who would make Belial weep with shame?" Victoria hissed. "WHY didn't you have ten times the guards you normally do on-site? This facility should have been CRAWLING with our people! Just look at all these empty gaps! It's no wonder he could stroll right in while barely encountering any resistance."

"With all due respect!" Claire finally shouted, the last vestige of her sanity breaking. She whirled around in her chair and faced her cousin directly. "We had plenty of personnel! Have you even reviewed the footage?! He walked within feet of dozens of armed guards, but no matter what the reality would have implied, he always managed to evade detection. Don't you see? We might be dealing with someone possessing Lowborn powers! That's the only explanation for how he entered so easily!"

Victoria fell silent. She leaned back and crossed her arms. Then, she shook her head.

"Oh, I saw the footage, Claire. Did you?"

"Of course I did! It's all I've been doing! Watching angle after angle of this man making a mockery of all my hard work!" Claire practically shrieked. "What more do you want from me?!"

After a few moments, Victoria gestured to one of the video feeds. "Jump to 4:07 AM. Camera 115-A."

Claire grumbled under her breath, but did as she was told. It didn't take her long to find the footage of 'Cat Mask' standing before the locked door. She had reviewed this particular moment more times than the rest.

"Yes? What about it?" Claire asked.

"You didn't notice?" Victoria asked, curling up her lip in mock disappointment. "Oh, Claire. I expected better from you. Look at the moment before he types in the code. See how his body seems to vibrate for a few seconds?"

Claire blinked. "Yes. I've noticed it. What about it? Isn't that just a camera artifact?"

"No." Victoria said, her eyes shining as she looked at the paused video. "It's not. I counted thirteen other instances of him pausing while his body vibrated for a moment before he continued forward and did something unbelievable. Furthermore..."

Victoria reached into her pocket and pulled out a piece of paper. She placed it in Claire's hand.

Claire frowned. She opened it up to see several numbers, and a chart showing a spike in certain energy levels. Her body jolted with shock.

"No... this... this isn't possible!"

"It is. It explains everything." Victoria said, finally relaxing her original expression. She no longer appeared as pissed as before. "Another Trueborn. A much older one. There are *two* Trueborn Heroes in the world. Jason Hiro was taken by the other one."

Claire's eyes started rapidly flickering as she quickly drew all sorts of conclusions based on this new information.

"Then... all the spikes of Heroic Power in different countries... those weren't Jason? They were this 'Cat Mask'?"

"He's been hiding himself well. We always expected there to only be one Trueborn, so we didn't account for the possibility of a second. It's entirely possible nobody but us possesses this information right now. I've taken the liberty to erase all data points leading someone to a similar conclusion. That paper in your hand is the last piece of hard evidence we still possess. But if true, it opens up a lot of... uncomfortable questions."

"You can say that again." Claire muttered, as her eyes fell to the ground. "Two Trueborn... are they related? *Blood* related?"

"It's possible, though unlikely." Victoria said, before shaking her head. "If they are related, then why didn't this 'Cat Mask' pick up Jason earlier in his life? Why wait until Jason is inside one of the most secure locations in the USA? Was it all simply to flex on us? To make a mockery of the Illuminati? I think not."

"It's more plausible Cat Mask learned about Jason from us." Claire responded, furrowing her brow. "We must have a leak. Someone feeding intelligence outside."

"Not necessarily." Victoria retorted. "Think about it. With the infiltration skills Cat Mask displayed, he must have an extremely diverse set of powers we can't possibly imagine. Based on his height, body build, and other parameters, we estimate he could be anywhere from thirty to sixty years old. His hair appears to be vibrant and youthful, so I personally lean toward the younger side of the axis. But even so! He has around two decades of experience. He's been a busy man, systematically taking down important and influential figures across the world. We're not dealing with some low-level amateur Trueborn. He might just be an Arthur-level powerhouse."

Claire's back turned icy at that thought.

An Arthur-level powerhouse? Inconceivable.

How could such a terrifying Trueborn lay low for so long, carefully hiding in the shadows while evading detection? What purpose could he have in sneaking into their base and stealing away Jason Hiro from right under their noses?

"Are you sure we... we aren't overestimating him?" Claire asked cautiously. "If he's so reluctant to show his face, he might not be as formidable as you believe."

"I don't disagree." Victoria said, touching her lip. "The fact he waited so long to show himself likely hints he is afraid of detection. His physical abilities might not be incredible, meaning he has to rely on long-range combat and the element of surprise to take down his enemies. His ability to fight demons is also potentially at the level of ordinary humans. He may only be a top-level infiltrator and saboteur."

She shook her head. "But that also might not be the case. We don't have enough information. For now, I want to treat him as a high-level asset and value him accordingly.

If we manage to encounter him in the field, we should proceed with extreme caution. He could be a friend or a foe."

"What about Jason Hiro?" Claire asked. "Do you have an idea on how to recover him?"

Victoria's expression hardened. She glared at Claire, her ruthlessness coming back with a vengeance. "Of course I don't know, imbecile. You're the one who lost him! You had a goddamned Trueborn fall out of the sky, right into your lap, and you fumbled the ball! You have truly embarrassed the-"

Suddenly, in the middle of Victoria's ranting, an alarm roared to life inside the Haven, silencing her in an instant. Her blood turned cold as she quickly looked around in confusion. Then, her eyes fell on one of the security monitors showing the front gate.

"No... impossible... why would he...?"

Recommended Listening

"Shoot him! Fucking SHOOT HIM! Where are you AIMING?!"

The leader of the Illuminati Internal Guard was practically ripping the hair out of his head. He watched in horror as a man wearing a Japanese nekomimi mask casually danced into the center of the Illuminati's central outer compound, shaking his ass, moonwalking, bending over backward, sometimes spinning gracefully like a ballet dancer.

Cat Mask seemed to glide forward, unobstructed, while more than thirty men and women shot at him with what should have been unerring accuracy. These were not ordinary, run of the mill guards one might find sauntering around a mall. All of them were battle-hardened ex-military personnel, many of whom had done tours of duty in various war-ravaged countries. Some of them had even seen and survived combat against Demon Lords and Barons.

Yet none of them were able to land a shot on Cat Mask!

Blat-blat-blat!

BRRRRRRT!

RAT-TAT-TAT-TAT!

Shotguns, rifles, machine guns, assault rifles, and many types of guns shot at Cat Mask, yet his seemingly bizarre movements somehow made him impossible to pin down.

No matter how many bullets flew, Cat Mask dodged all of them, leaving a trail of bullet holes in the ground and walls behind him. He flipped his body, leaped into the air, spun upside down, and landed on one hand right in front of a man aiming a pistol at his previous position. Then Cat Mask snapped his leg at the man's face and kicked him with enough force to break his nose and send him collapsing into his shadow.

Cat Mask instantly flipped off his hand, spun in midair, and landed right on his crotch, performing a split that would make Olympic gymnasts green with envy. Then he aimed the same device he'd used a few days earlier at the face of a female guard, and she crumpled as well.

One by one, systematically, Cat Mask danced from left to right, spinning with terrifying elegance and grace as he took out one guard after another. By the time reinforcements had started to trickle in, most of the initial thirty guards were already down! In just shy of two minutes, Cat Mask took out so many of the Illuminati's forces that a palpable sense of terror had seized hold of the few remaining conscious guards.

"AHHHH! Why can't I hit you?! Die! DIE, you demon!!"

One man screamed in a panic. His pants filled with piss as he saw Cat Mask start moving toward him. His movements inexorable, inevitable, Cat Mask could not be stopped as he danced over to the man, aimed something at his face, and his vision went black.

"Demon! He has to be a demon!" The leader of the guards shouted.

Cat Mask clapped his hands together. He spun around and pointed his arm up, as if dancing to an unknown disco tune. Then he spun on his toes and sent a raised kick flying at the head of the guard commander.

THUMP.

The lead guard hit the ground like a sack of potatoes. After him, there would be no-one else for at least thirty seconds.

Cat Mask paused for half a beat. Then he resumed dancing, but this time not bothering to move toward anything in particular. He spun his fists around each other and thrust his hips multiple times, clearly having the time of his life.

Inside the bunker, Victoria and Claire both stared, slack-jawed, as this incredibly bizarre person who was clearly not well in the head continued to dance, dabbing and hip-

thrusting atop his fallen foes as if this were nothing more than points racked up in a game to him.

Claire's eyes twitched. She looked at Victoria with gritted teeth.

"*What were you saying* about Trueborn falling out of the sky?" Claire hissed.

Victoria's eyes suddenly widened. "What the- look! Behind him! At the entrance... isn't that... Jason Hiro?!"

Claire quickly snapped her eyes toward the monitor. She watched as Jason casually strolled over to Cat Mask, stopped, and stared with a strange expression as the masked man continued to bizarrely dance in place to some silent song nobody but him could hear.

Jason shook his head. Then he glanced up at the nearest camera, pointed his finger, and made a curling motion with it.

The meaning was obvious.

Come here.

Claire felt like her world was imploding. She looked at Victoria, and Victoria looked back at her. Clearly, neither of them had expected something like this to happen.

"W...what do we do?" Claire asked.

Her cousin looked defeated. "Well. They didn't kill anyone. Let's go see what they want."

Minutes later, a tense standoff followed. Jason stood with his hands on his hips, while Victoria and Claire stood over fifty feet away, looking visibly tense. Behind them, dozens of guards stood with guns trained on Jason and Cat Mask both, but nobody pulled the trigger. They weren't entirely certain what the hell was going on.

Oh, and Cat Mask was dancing. Still. He hadn't stopped.

"*Dad.*" Jason hissed, grabbing his father's shoulder. "Stop it. You're embarrassing me."

"Oh, lighten up." Cat Mask said, finally stopping his rampage of dance moves. He looked at his son and smirked under his mask. "Dancing's fun. It's good to cut loose once in a while. You should try it sometime."

"*There is a time and a place-!*" Jason hissed, before giving up. "Never mind. Just be serious for a few minutes."

Cat Mask crossed his arms. He looked off to the side and huffed. "Fine. Whatever."

Victoria and Claire couldn't quite make out what Jason had said to Cat Mask, but it was obvious that the two men were surprisingly close. Hadn't they only known each other for a couple of days? Or had they met previously?

"Jason..." Claire said, forcing an awkward smile. "You returned."

"Sorry about all the commotion." Jason said, directing a slightly looser smile back at her. He crossed his arms. "My... *companion*... can fly a little off the handle. But he's a good guy. He only kills bad people."

Claire nodded wordlessly.

Before she could reply, her cousin took a step forward.

"Jason Hiro. We haven't been formally introduced. I planned to meet you, but your *companion* whisked you away before I could arrive. My name is-"

"Victoria Rothschild." Cat Mask suddenly said, interrupting her mid-sentence. "Current head of the Illuminati."

Victoria didn't visibly react to Cat Mask's interruption. It was easily conceivable he knew who she was, given she was not exactly low-profile.

"And you are... 'Cat Mask'?" Victoria asked.

"Nice to meet you." Cat Mask responded dryly.

Victoria remained quiet for a moment.

"I have it on good authority that you are both Trueborn." Victoria said. "Related to one another, possibly?"

She expected to see Jason's expression change ever so slightly. Perhaps he might flinch, or might give her a clue about his relationship to Cat Mask. But he remained stone-faced.

"We met for the first time two days ago." Jason explained. "When he extracted me from your complex. Cat Mask shed some light on my abilities, and showed me what my powers are capable of."

Jason didn't elaborate, leaving Victoria and Claire to wonder just what new abilities Cat Mask had helped Jason uncover. One thing was for sure, though. Everything about Jason seemed different from a few days ago. He stood taller, he seemed more confident,

and his eyes had become more world-weary than when Claire last met him. Before, he had already seemed wise beyond his years, but now the feeling was truly palpable.

Was he *only* eighteen years old?

"So." Victoria said slowly. "Why have you returned? And in such a... unique manner."

She glanced at the fallen bodies on the ground. Some of the injured had already picked themselves back up, but all of them were suffering from the same nausea and other after-effects as the guards originally taken down by Cat Mask's unique incapacitation device.

"It turns out my business here wasn't complete." Jason said. "My partner and I consider each other equals. He was against me returning, but I insisted. I need to speak with your ancestors again."

Claire's eyes shone. She looked at Jason with bewilderment. It was naturally great that he wanted to return, but why would Cat Mask bring him back after going to such troubles to break him out before?

Then again... was it really all that great of trouble? Considering how unbelievable Cat Mask was at infiltration, combat, and other things...

Claire wanted to kick herself. What was she talking about with Victoria earlier? What did she have the guts to say? To imply Cat Mask was some weakling with no combat powers? It was plainly obvious he could wipe out a regiment of soldiers with no trouble whatsoever! If he wanted their guards dead, he could have done so right from the start. He even took the more 'difficult' path of walking in and facing them in hand-to-hand range before non-lethally incapacitating them.

Cat Mask was absolutely, irrevocably on a similar level to Arthur! Perhaps not in terms of raw damage, but in terms of sheer prowess, the two could definitely be said to be similar!

"You want to speak to them?" Victoria asked. Her gaze sharpened. "If you've come here intending to destroy their artifacts, I can assure you that *fancy dance moves* will neither protect you, nor prevent me from self-destructing this facility atop your heads."

"Calm down." Jason said, waving a hand casually. "I'm a Hero. So is Cat Mask. We are not *Dracula*. We have no intention of harming our fellow ancestors. If anything, my return here bodes well for a future cooperation between us and the Illuminati. If you wish, you can ask the ancestor's permission first. We'll wait."

Victoria hesitated. She really couldn't tell if Jason had been brainwashed, or if what he said was true. What exactly was his relation with this mysterious 'Cat Mask'? Why had she never heard of Cat Mask outside minor incident reports over the years? And why make himself so visible now, all of a sudden? Things weren't adding up.

But, compared with losing the trust of the Trueborn, humanity's greatest weapon against the angels and demons... her complaints ultimately meant little.

"Alright." Victoria said. "Claire, stay here and entertain our guests for a bit. I will return within the hour."

Claire nodded heavily. "Alright."

Without another word, Victoria turned and strode away, leaving Claire sitting in her wheelchair.

Jason's expression become a little lighter after Victoria left. He glanced at the guards behind Claire, then back at the woman herself.

"So, uh, Claire. How is Natalie? Is she alright?"

"Natalie is fine. She was punished for failing to protect you." Claire explained. "Not heavily punished, but discipline must be maintained."

"Alright." Jason said. "Good. It wasn't her fault."

Minutes passed. Jason and everyone else remained completely silent, simply staring at one another. Cat Mask grew so bored that he started dancing again, which caused everyone to tense up. Even when Jason hissed at him to stop, Cat Mask continued. It turned out he *really* loved dancing.

A little over half an hour later, Victoria returned. She paused and frowned, seeing Cat Mask break dancing to some silent, unheard tune, but wisely chose to remain silent about the matter and simply shook her head instead.

"Jason, you have permission to enter. But not Cat Mask." Victoria said, tensing up under the fear Cat Mask might lash out in anger.

Instead, he just kept dancing, ignoring the conversation as if it didn't matter anymore. Jason appeared bemused by her visible palpitation.

"Cool. We'll do that then. Stay here, Cat Mask. I'll be back."

Cat Mask simply grunted. "Yeah yeah, shut it, kid. You're throwing off my groove!"

Jason left his father behind, and Victoria found herself and Claire flanking the young Trueborn, wondering why he would be so confident as to stroll into their base completely alone. Surely, he might fear the Illuminati could hurt him, mind-control him, or something else?

Then again, with such an unstoppable ally break-dancing outside, the Illuminati were sure to be on their best behavior.

"Your companion is an... interesting character." Claire said, glancing at Jason after they were out of Cat Mask's earshot.

"If only you knew." Jason chuckled.

Part 627: The Human Conspiracy

January 16th, 2021. 9AM. Illuminati Haven.

Jason walked with both of the Rothschild descendants beside him, Claire rolling in her wheelchair on his left, and Victoria on his right. They traveled down into the Illuminati's underground bunker, and when they reached the elevator that would take them to the bottom level, after they stepped inside and began to descend, Victoria turned to him.

"Aren't you even a little bit worried?" She asked.

"That you'll betray me?" Jason asked. He smirked. "Our interests align. I feel no threat from you. Even if you tried something, I promise you, it would turn out very badly. I'm not the same man I was two days ago."

Victoria nodded silently. What she did not know was that as she stood there looking at Jason, he was intrusively reading her mind without her knowledge.

Thanks to Jason's Wordsmithing, even if he could not yet recreate the powerful artifacts he possessed in the future, he could still passively grant himself a handful of incredible abilities. These abilities were once his bread and butter. They now felt a little primitive and limited, but in fact they were insanely overpowered compared to what an ordinary human like Victoria could perform.

I don't know if I can trust him. Victoria thought to herself, unaware that Jason's disarming smile held a deep level of scrutiny. *Who knows if that Cat Mask brainwashed him? And how is Cat Mask related to Jason? The fact Jason willingly walked out with him could mean they had a prior arrangement. Is this all some sort of ploy to harm the Ancestors...?*

Jason decided to address her criticisms indirectly. Taking care not to reveal his newly enhanced abilities, he cleared his throat and turned his head to look at the elevator door.

"You look worried, Claire. There's no need to be alarmed. I will absolutely not harm the Ancestors. The Earth is facing a serious crisis. I will need both of their help if we are to weather the future storm."

Victoria frowned. "A crisis? Of what sort?"

"I will leave it to them to explain to you if they so desire." Jason said, before pausing for a moment. "No offense, but this matter can only be passed on to those I consider my equals. You are not among that small group."

Victoria nodded. Her frown did not disappear. *He doesn't think I'm his equal? Then does that mean he only looks at other Trueborn in such a positive light? Should I try pressing him for more information? But then again, working with Jason benefits the Illuminati, assuming he does possess some sort of formidable power. I wouldn't want to push him away…*

Jason forced himself not to smile. He maintained a neutral expression while thinking his own thoughts.

He would not willingly give Claire or Victoria any unnecessary information.

This was not a decision made out of malice. In fact, he would love to keep them informed if at all possible. But the truth was, if he could casually read their minds, then so could others. It would not do for them to have knowledge of his powers or future events rolling about in their heads. Who knew when a powerful Psion might randomly scan their minds and uncover alarming secrets Jason didn't want them to know?

Jason could grant them the Mind of Void, but that would only make them more suspicious. Better to limit need-to-know information to only those who could use it most effectively.

The elevator stopped, then opened up. Claire and Victoria both hesitated, but Jason beckoned to them. "You don't trust me. That's fine. Come along, both of you. I will be speaking to the Ancestors privately, but you can stand and watch in case I try to blow the place up or something."

Victoria's heart skipped a beat. Jason winced, realizing his words came off as somewhat in bad taste. It was too late to undo it, so he just waved his hand. "That was a joke, Victoria."

"Not a funny one…" Victoria muttered.

Not wanting to delay further, Jason quickly power-walked into the central underground area. The familiar statues of ancient Heroes stood in the center, but unlike his previous appearance, Jason recognized many of them.

"Arthur." Jason said, gesturing to one of the statues. "No Excalibur?"

Victoria slowly shook her head, giving Jason a weird look. "We do not possess Arthur's relic. That belongs to the Knights Templar. They are a fellow militant faction dedicated to the legend of Arthur. They also possess the relic of the next Hero in line; Sir Lorent Berthold of Camelot."

Jason's heart skipped a beat. Lorent was Phoebe's nephew!

"I'm surprised." Jason said, keeping his voice even. "I thought Camael would claim ownership of Excalibur."

Another flash of surprise passed over Victoria's face. Whoever Cat Mask was, he had truly fed Jason a lot of privileged information!

"Camael passed the Divine Blade to humanity when she gave it to King Arthur. Like Solomon's Crown and many other artifacts, she made no effort to reclaim them following their wielder's deaths. Considering the Heroic Spirits inside would reject her ownership, she might not have had any choice. Excalibur in particular is a powerful artifact filled with pride. It will not let anyone but a select few wield it. Specifically, Trueborn descendants. And even then, Arthur has become even pickier following the antics of a certain Trueborn a few hundred years ago."

Jason nodded. "Dracula. Understandable."

Victoria tried to hide the shock on her face, but she failed. Just how much information did Cat Mask give Jason? Compared to Claire's description of his previous information, it was as if he'd devoured an entire encyclopedia of information about the world around him. The more they chatted, the more she realized his knowledge encompassed Heroes, Angels, Demons, and many other notable Truths.

As they drew closer to the central garden, Jason turned to look at Victoria.

"Cat Mask unlocked my true power." Jason explained. "I am a Seer, Victoria. I have foreseen many terrible things that will someday come to pass. My ability to obtain information is perhaps at the highest level you can imagine. Aside from that, I dare not leak this information beyond those who are most privileged. I am not being vague to spite you, but because I fear the capabilities of enemies you cannot yet fathom."

Victoria nodded. She and Claire exchanged a glance, both of them feeling that Jason's words contained a severity and gravitas they were only barely able to pick up on.

Just how formidable were his 'seer' powers? What future events had he glimpsed?

Jason cleared his throat. "It's time. I'll be going ahead now."

Without waiting for Victoria's pardon, Jason turned and strode forward. He closed his eyes, and immediately, his vision dimmed as a pair of powerful presences materialized inside his Mind Realm.

This time though, the situation was different. Madam Mildred blinked in surprise when she appeared, realizing that she was no longer able to overpower Jason's soul and force him inside her 'domain'. Instead, she had become a guest inside his mind, as had Jepthath. The ancient Hero-King also noticed this discrepency.

Several seconds passed. Both ancient Heroes assessed the situation and realized they could pull themselves out with a single thought. Jason had somehow instantly transitioned from a cute junior they could bully into an equal possessing a clear mastery of some as-yet unfathomable abilities. They had never witnessed such a rapid and frightening transition in all their years alive!

"Oh... ho-ho-ho!" Mildred finally chortled, looking at Jason with shining eyes. "What's this? The lad has become a man? You are much more intriguing than before, Little Jason! Or should I say... *Big* Jason?"

"It's just Jason." He replied blandly. "Mildred. Long time, no speak."

Mildred paused. She cocked her head slightly.

Long time? But hadn't they spoken just two days before? Why did Jason's words convey the impression of a much deeper relationship between the two of them?

"Ah ha-ha-ha! Dear boy, you are becoming more interesting every second!" Mildred chirped. "And what is this new barrier surrounding your mind? I cannot read even the surface level of your thoughts!"

"Oh, good." Jason said, nodding to himself. "I wasn't sure if it would work on you. I suppose you could be lying, but you've always been a rather truthful woman. Certainly compared to Solomon."

His words once again baffled Mildred. Had Jason spoken to Solomon recently? But again, he implied a deep knowledge of the man, something he could not obtain in a single day. Solomon was indeed a bit of a deceiver, but this was not something a casual acquaintance could easily uncover.

"Jason." Jepthath said, lifting his chin to look at Jason with an even gaze. "What is your reason for returning? Are you able to speak frankly, or has that other Trueborn manipulated you in some way?"

Jason looked at Jepthath for a moment. Then he closed his eyes and lowered his head.

"We should start from the beginning."

He inhaled a breath, then exhaled. He opened his eyes and met Mildred and Jepthath's gazes.

"My name is Jason Hiro." Jason said. "But I am not the Jason you knew from two days ago. I am a time traveler. I sent my mind back in time from a very, very, very distant future. More than 100,000 years from now, as it happens."

Jason continued to speak. As he did, Mildred and Jepthath fell completely silent. They listened with rapt attention to a tale that sounded so absurd it could only make sense when placed in the context of an even more absurd Heroic ability.

Jason did not hold back. Unlike with Claire and Victoria, he spoke earnestly and frankly. He told the two Heroes before him basically every piece of pertinent information.

"...The Volgrim will attack Earth at some point in the future, roughly twenty to forty years from now. Depending on how events play out, the timeline can shift dramatically."

"...The Earth is ultimately destroyed by the Volgrim using one of their many superweapons."

"...I learned of this information from my father, Hideki Hiro. He is also known as Cat Mask, and is the Trueborn waiting outside."

"...My power is called Wordsmithing. I am able to manifest things into reality via a single Word of Power."

"...There was a demon named Gressil. He possessed the power of Chaos, and altered future events so that I would be driven to despair and go back in time."

"...Ultimately, Maiura fell to these 'Kolvaxians'. Then, Tarus II fell under the power of the Psion leader, Dosena."

By the time Jason finished explaining all the broad strokes, the other two Heroes had fallen so silent that an outside observer could hear a pin drop.

Mildred no longer appeared exuberant and boisterous. Her expression became extremely clear and sober. She swallowed heavily.

"These… events. They are too absurd to be fiction, dear boy."

"They must be real." Jepthath concluded. "It explains all the bizarre happenings around you."

Jason nodded. "Yeah."

He remained silent for several minutes. Neither of the other two Heroes said anything. They fell completely silent, allowing themselves time to think about this matter and privately communicate with one another. Jason wasn't too surprised to find that, like how Mildred could not read his mind, he could not read hers. Jepthath also appeared to be under her protection, so Jason could not glean information about their silent dialogue through the Hero-King's brain.

Finally, Mildred spoke.

"To say that this matter is 'troubling' would be a terrible understatement. Jason, why did you come to us? Are we able to assist you?"

"I came here for your help specifically, Mildred." Jason replied. "But Jepthath, your abilities will also make a material difference in this future war. I alone am not capable of defending humanity from the full power of the Volgrim. Their Second Founder alone can atomize my body with a single thought. Their army of 7th and 8th Level Psions are all Cosmic Entities, meaning they can destroy planets if they so desire. The only way for humanity to stand strong is if we work together and unite under a common purpose."

Jepthath's eyes flashed. "Cosmic Entities. This is the first I have heard of such a term. Can you elaborate?"

Jason nodded. "Let's first discuss what the different 'levels' of mortal power mean."

Jason first launched into an explanation about the different tiers of power demons wielded.

"First there are imps, which are weaker than humans. After that come Demon Grunts and Peons, then Lords, Barons, Dukes, and Emperors. For context, a Volgrim Psion of the 4th or 5th Level is about the power of an Emperor. Then there's a strange gap; the 6th Level Psions are stronger than Emperors, but are not Cosmics. 7th Level Psions are Bottom Level Cosmics, 8th are Low Cosmics, and 9th are Middle Cosmics. But you likely

don't know that demons can break past the rank of Emperor to become a new entity known as a Demon Deity."

"Demon Deity?" Jepthath asked, his eyes flashing with hatred. "So Emperor is not the limit?"

"No." Jason said, unaware that Beelzebub had already reached a level beyond Emperor but below Deity in the future he left behind. "Demon Deities appear to wield different levels of power. Unlike the Volgrim, who categorize their different levels of strength, the Demon Deities range in strength but are all referred to by the same title. It can get confusing, I know."

He then proceeded to explain the concept of Akashic Backlashes, which made Mildred furrow her brows.

"That means Cosmics have a weakness that becomes more pronounced the more powerful they are. The 8th Level Psions will not be eager to involve themselves in a war with Earth. The Second Founder especially will not."

"But she took direct action to obliterate Tarus II." Jason retorted, his anger flaring up for a moment. "That villain cannot be trusted."

"I disagree." Jepthath said. "You described a future where the Volgrim were surrounded by the Plague on all fronts. It seems more likely Dosena was one of only a few free enough to attack your world. That is why she attacked despite knowing she would suffer a terrible Akashic Backlash. In this era, she will not make a move unless the situation is truly dire. Likewise, the 8th Level Psions will hesitate to threaten their power unless necessary. We will have to face 7th Level Psions, at the worst."

Mildred's expression darkened. "You speak as if this is a small matter, Jepthath. 7th Level Psions could still wipe out Demon Emperors with a single thought. Nothing and nobody on Earth is their match, save perhaps the Archangels and certain Titan Kings, including Zeus. I fear that even Jason will not be able to pose them a serious threat. And if he does? The Volgrim still have Executors and their Second Founder in the back-wing."

All three Heroes became eerily quiet as they carefully rolled this information around in their craniums. Mildred especially worked overtime to think about what Jason had told her.

"...Alright, dear boy. We will help you." Mildred said, speaking on behalf of herself and Jepthath. "What abilities can we provide that your Wordsmithing cannot?"

"I only need your help directly in these early stages." Jason explained. "Though, later on, your talents will still become extremely valuable. But let's focus on the short term."

Jason cleared his throat.

"Mildred. I need you to help me construct a mental supercomputer inside my Mind Realm. Originally, my wife's clone, Fiona, did this. However, she is not available and I need to act in secrecy without alerting the demons or Volgrim. You are the best candidate. Once my supercomputer is finished, I can use it to enhance my Wordsmithing, to construct secret safe havens for humanity, and to prepare for the future war."

Jason motioned with his hands. He summoned a magical blackboard with words written on it, words he had written when he spoke to his father a couple days before.

MANIFEST ORIGINAL POWERS AND ABILITIES

CONSTRUCT TIME ACCELERATED REALM

REMAIN ICOGNITO: PLAGUE NOT YET A FACTOR, FULL VOLGRIM MILITARY STRUCTURE INTACT...

Mildred and Jepthath read through the bullet points. They nodded, understanding Jason's grand plans.

"These outlines are somewhat sloppy, but I get the gist of what you need, dear boy." Mildred said. "First, empower yourself. Then, construct a time-accelerated realm. Once inside, work quickly and furiously to rebuild your former base of power. Finally, use this new strength to swiftly launch decapitation strikes. Take out key demon leaders, humans, Volgrim, and so on. Attack from the shadows. Keep your enemies guessing. Never let on the truth behind your powers."

Jepthath smiled in a somewhat horrifying and evil manner. "Make these bloodskins feel fear, eh? I must say, I like the way you think, Jason. I am pleased to offer my services to such a competent Hero. It's about time a fearsome junior arrived on the scene."

"Genocide is on the table." Jason explained. "But that doesn't mean I want to take such a path. It would be preferable to maintain Earth's diversity and unite all our species against the Volgrim. In fact, had the Volgrim not betrayed me so vilely, I might have wanted to try and unite with them too. There are, after all, horrors in the *Unknown*.

Preparing for the arrival of the Plague should be our top priority, but we will have to treat the Volgrim as our main threat for now."

Jason's explanations had truly given Mildred and Jepthath a lot to chew on. They looked at one another, no longer confident about Earth's future prospects. Their enemy was a species that had swallowed the entire galaxy, and Earth was nothing more than a curiosity to these aliens. It was no threat. It could not possibly become a threat for a very long time, either.

Only with the concerted effort of the Wordsmith and his allies would humanity have a shred of a chance at surviving the future war.

The Energy Wars would test humanity. Would it falter and break, or would it rise up to meet and defeat this challenge?

Jepthath felt a swelling of ambition in his chest. How could he allow his species to fall? He had the ability to grant it a piece of future potential: Potential which might someday blossom into warriors capable of battling Cosmics! Under Jason, he could realize his powers in a way he wouldn't have been able to when he was alive!

For Jepthath, this war has always been personal. The Demons tried to slaughter his species. They killed his wife and children. His family. His descendants.

One atrocity after another. The demons never stopped, always pushing to cause him the deepest possible anguish at any given moment in time.

But gradually, his heart hardened. He became unbreakable. He gained the determination to never stop fighting back.

Perhaps Solomon might long for death, but Jepthath never did. He only sought one outcome: The complete extinction of his enemies.

And now? He had to add another species to that hit list. The Volgrim would *pay* for their future crimes.

"So." Jepthath said. "When can we begin the work?"

"Today. Right now, even." Jason answered. "Time waits for no man."

Part 628: Jason, "The Idiot" Trueborn

January 16th, 2021. Noon. Illuminati Haven.

Three hours passed. Claire sat in her wheelchair, and Victoria remained standing, shifting the weight of her feet around as her progressively more pained feet cried out, begging for a reprieve. She couldn't help but direct sneaky looks of jealousy to her cousin, who didn't have to suffer the agony of three hours standing in a pair of high heels. Truly, some people had all the luck.

Well. To be fair, the man who put Claire in the wheelchair was no stroke of good luck for her. But that was years ago, and the accident had likely long faded into a distant, traumatic memory.

Victoria felt a little bad, envying her cousin. But at the same time, as the leader of the Illuminati, she could not break decorum by sitting on the floor, or leaving to fetch a seat. She had no idea what the Ancestors were discussing with Jason, but as he stood there, his head, bowed, unmoving, she could only assume it was a matter of grave importance.

Victoria tried to distract herself with random thoughts. She mentally planned out her itinerary for the next several weeks, crossing items on and off. That only lasted for half an hour before her feet cramped up and sent bolts of lightning shooting from the arches of her feet to her knees.

Damn. Damn damn damn. Her feet really hurt. If only she could just take her shoes off and stand barefoot, her agony would lessen ever so slightly.

She wanted to do it. She truly did. But if there was one thing Victoria cared about more than her own personal comfort, it was maintaining the sanctity of her Heroic lineage. Her Ancestor wasn't just a formidable human, but the savior of the human species. The progenitor of all humans who came after! He was their guiding light. Their Illuminator.

What was a little foot pain compared to upholding the honor of his existence?

So, she stood still and suffered. Each pang of pain only firmed her resolve further.

Eventually, Jason stirred. He lifted his head and a wave of relief washed down Victoria's body, making her feel like she'd gained five years of her youth back.

Jason looked around and blinked. Then he turned to Claire and Victoria.

"...Are you alright?" Jason asked, looking at Victoria. "You're sweating a lot."

Victoria silently swore in her head. *Dammit! I didn't know I looked so miserable! My feet are killing me, but I can't look weak in front of the Trueborn. I have to maintain the Illuminati's image!*

She grunted. "It's nothing. A small matter. Was your discussion with the Ancestors fruitful?"

Jason didn't immediately respond. He gave her a funny smile, as if he knew something she didn't. Victoria had no idea Jason could read minds and she'd practically screamed about her pain directly at his face, albeit unwillingly.

"A small matter, huh? Well, it's none of my business." Jason said. "The Ancestors want to speak with you, Victoria. Specifically, Jepthath. The three of us came to an agreement, and he's going to fill you in on the broad strokes."

Victoria's eye twitched. It was a great honor to speak to the Ancestors. She had only done so on three previous occasions, and always, it was only Jepthath who communicated with her. Madam Mildred never deigned to speak with her or almost any of the former Illuminati heads unless it was an emergency. Victoria didn't know why, but secretly she thought Mildred might be somewhat arrogant, stuck-up, and maybe full of herself.

Not that Victoria would ever dare to utter such thoughts out loud. Mildred had every right to feel arrogant. She was a superior human who once stood at the apex of humanity's power. Compared to her, mundane humans like Victoria were nothing at all.

The only problem Victoria had now was that her feet hurt so badly she really didn't want to stand in place and worsen her situation further. Even so, she had no choice! It was her obligation as the Illuminati Head to commune with Jepthath anytime he requested a meeting.

She quickly nodded. "Of course. I shall do so at once."

She closed her eyes and stilled her mind. Moments later, she appeared inside a white void where a familiar man stood before her, towering over her with his abundant spirituality, his presence like a mountain before a pebble.

"My descendant." Jepthath said, his voice booming. "From this day forward, the Illuminati shall serve Jason Hiro as his closest advisor, ally, and asset. Any command he issues, you will follow. His voice should be considered equal to mine."

Victoria blinked. This was not what she expected to hear.

"Ancestor Jepthath… I… you are saying…?"

"I am not compromised." Jepthath said. "The boy is powerful. Truly formidable. His powers may be the greatest of any Trueborn that has ever lived. Humanity is fortunate to have such a powerhouse appearing before the advent of a dark future. With Jason Hiro leading us, we may yet weather the coming storm."

A chill went down Victoria's spine. Hearing Jepthath's words, either Jason had used his heroic abilities to completely seize control of the Ancestors, or he had spoken of a future so frightening that they immediately threw down their pride to serve him.

Either way, Jason was this generation's Trueborn. Victoria had no problem following his orders, and neither could she resist if he held any evil intentions. Cat Mask alone potentially had the strength to obliterate the Illuminati. If Jason was as terrifying as Jepthath stated, then Jason and Cat Mask together must be an awe-inspiring force of nature she couldn't fathom!

"I understand, Ancestor." Victoria said, lowering her head. "As you command. The Illuminati shall now heed all commands Jason Hiro issues as if they were spoken by you personally."

She expected Jepthath to dismiss her, but instead, he kept her within his domain for a while longer.

"You have doubts." Jepthath stated. "You fear that Jason has subverted my mind, as well as Mildred's. I assure you, he has not. That boy is a worthy inheritor of the Heroic Aura. He spoke to me in clear and convincing terms of a future where humanity would fall. His arguments were sound of logic, and Mildred herself could find no reproach within his words. The time we have left before the Earth's demise is not long, not long at all. We must act quickly if we are to preserve humanity's sovereignty."

His eyes filled with solemn duty, Jepthath lifted his head as if to search the void for Heaven's whereabouts.

"Jason does not need the Illuminati's resources. Not directly. He can easily replicate everything that we possess using his own powers. However, our heritage is formidable. Our millennia of experience. Our manpower. Our network of talents. Our ability to collect and disseminate information. We are not serving him because we must, but because our

greatest Test is soon to reveal itself. If we do not rise to meet it, then only destruction will follow. Humanity is counting on us, my child. We will not falter, though our enemies appear insurmountable."

Victoria nodded silently. She no longer questioned her Ancestor's motivations. Whatever he had seen, whatever tale Jason had spun, it must have spooked him beyond anything he'd witnessed before.

This was no small matter. The Illuminati, and humanity itself, could not afford to fall into complacency.

"I will put our full power into action, Ancestor." Victoria swore. "This, I promise."

"Very good. Then go in peace, my daughter. Soon enough, you will be fortunate to witness miracles in the making."

Victoria's vision shimmered. Jepthath disappeared along with the white void, and she found herself back in the underground chamber.

Surprisingly, Victoria found that her feet no longer hurt, and her body was full of energy. This was strange, because such a thing had never happened during the previous times she spoke to her Ancestor.

She lifted her eyes to see Jason smiling at her.

"Feet feeling better?" Jason asked.

"I... yes?" Victoria asked, trying not to sound completely bewildered. "But... how did you know..?"

Jason waved his hand flippantly. "Consider it my apology for leaving you hanging for all that time. I had no idea Jepthath, Mildred and I were going to hit things off so well."

Victoria wanted to respond, but her eyes nearly popped out of her head when Jason abruptly walked over to Jepthath's statue, took hold of his Shepherd's Staff, and yoinked it away from the statue for himself.

"W-what are you doing?!" Victoria cried, rendered aghast by the blatant disrespect for her Ancestor's artifact.

"Calm down." Jason said, raising an eyebrow at her. "Didn't Jepthath explain? From now on, the Illuminati is mine. That includes his artifact, and Mildred's. But don't worry. I'll only be using them for a while. A temporary crutch."

Victoria tried to suppress her distress, but the mere act of touching the Ancestor's artifact had been drilled into her from childhood as an act of disrespect and sacrilege. Jepthath was more than her Ancestor; he was the Illuminati's god!

Let alone just touching his staff, picking it up so casually felt like an affront to her lifetime of hard work. It took all her self control not to scream profanities at Jason.

And then, Jason walked right over to Mildred's artifact, a music box dated from the 1900s. He reached his hand out, then casually picked it up as well.

"No Kasim or Karla or Tucker this time, huh? Maybe in the future." Jason muttered.

Jason turned around. He twirled Jepthath's staff playfully, testing its weight in his hand. It wasn't a good fighting implement, and certainly not as well-balanced as a proper bo staff would be. He made a mental note that he'd need to craft formidable fighting weapons for his future battles.

Victoria stared at him with widened, horror-filled eyes. She felt nauseous, unable to process these developments. Never did she imagine her almighty Ancestors would have their artifacts treated like a street vendor's cabbage, simply picked up and played with for a teenager's amusement!

Seemingly oblivious to the horror on Victoria's face, Jason smiled jovially.

"Well, alrighty then! What are we waiting for? Let's head upstairs, ladies!"

Compared to Victoria, Claire seemed a lot less moved. She knew the Ancestors were viewed as gods by the Illuminati, but she had never spoken to them in person like Victoria had. She lacked a personal connection with Jepthath, so she really couldn't fully comprehend the depth of her cousin's despair.

Jason walked toward the elevator, and Claire joined him. Victoria was a few seconds slower, and she dragged her feet a little bit, still grappling with the change in dynamics that had abruptly played out less than a minute before.

"So." Jason said, some time later, when he arrived inside the central command area of the Illuminati Haven. "The first thing I need you to do is add a detailed listing of my powers to the Illuminati's files."

Victoria blinked. "That... are you certain?"

It was a baffling request. Why did this matter to Jason so much that he made it his first directive?

"I'm certain." Jason replied. He held out his hand, revealing a small SD Card. "I've taken the liberty to fill out my abilities for you to conveniently add. Make sure you have one of your scientists reword this information so it doesn't sound like something I wrote. I didn't have time to mask my own writing well."

Victoria's eyebrow furiously twitched. Jason's request was especially bizarre given he had been so careful about revealing his powers earlier, but now he was just handing the full outline to her??

Without delay, she plugged the memory card into a slot on the back of a nearby computer, then took a minute to load up the primary files.

On her screen, a series of words appeared.

SUBJECT NAME: JASON HIRO

CLASSIFICATION: TRUEBORN HERO, COMBAT AND SUPPORT SPECIALIST

POWER TYPE: INFORMATION WARFARE

HEROIC DESIGNATION: "ARCHSEER"

Butterflies fluttered in Victoria's stomach. It was real! This truly was a manifest of his powers. Everything lined up with what she and the other researchers had learned before, but now the information was far more detailed.

FIRST NOTED ABILITY: DREAM EATING. SUBJECT CAN OBTAIN INFORMATION WHEN ASLEEP. SUBJECT POSSESSES ACCESS TO SOMETHING HE REFERS TO AS THE 'DREAM NEXUS'. SUBJECT CAN LEARN INFORMATION ABOUT ENEMIES REMOTELY WITHOUT EVER COMING INTO CONTACT WITH THEM.

SECOND NOTED ABILITY: HYPER TRAINING. SUBJECT IS CAPABLE OF RAPIDLY ABSORBING PRACTICAL COMBAT ABILITIES FROM ALLIES AND FOES ALIKE DURING DREAM INCURSIONS. SUBJECT DEMONSTRATES INCREDIBLE REFLEXES AND AGILITY. SUBJECT CAN QUICKLY OBTAIN EXTREME COMMAND OF MARTIAL WEAPONRY WITH EASE.

Victoria's mind swirled as she assessed these notes. Was this how the Trueborn had become so formidable seemingly overnight? But if true, then why would he willingly tell her this information?

She immediately realized the truth. Jason wanted to win her over by demonstrating his trust in the Illuminati. There could be no secrets between him and her. By revealing his true powers, he was essentially saying he trusted her implicitly, and hoped she would do so as well.

The thought warmed her heart ever so slightly.

THIRD NOTED ABILITY: ENHANCED REFLEXES. SUBJECT HAS DEMONSTRATED AGILITY AND REFLEXES AT THE LEVEL OF A DEMON BARON. HE IS ABLE TO PERCEIVE TIME AT A NOTABLY HIGHER RATE OF SPEED THAN ORDINARY HUMANS, ALLOWING HIM TO REACT TO THREATS FASTER THAN NORMAL.

FOURTH NOTED ABILITY: FATIGUE ELIMINATION. SUBJECT POSSESSES EXTRAORDINARY ENDURANCE AND CAN ALLEVIATE FATIGUE ACCUMULATED OVER LONG PERIODS OF TIME. THIS ABILITY IS NOT LIMITED ONLY TO HIMSELF, BUT OTHER ENTITIES AS WELL. IT IS ESPECIALLY USEFUL FOR TRAINING HIS OWN BODY'S PHYSICAL PARAMETERS.

Several other entries followed. The more she read, the more she realized Jason Hiro was an extremely strong, combat and information-warfare focused Hero. While his abilities weren't too useful when it came to creating artifacts, healing severe injuries, or enhancing his own durability, in a head to head matchup, he could probably beat most Demon Dukes and even some of the Emperors under favorable circumstances.

Still, his lack of versatility was a notable flaw. If the demons ever learned of this weakness, they might try to seize upon it. That could prove a fatal disaster...

Concern wormed its way onto Victoria's face. She looked at Jason nervously, only to see a calm, confident smile on his face. Didn't he understand the danger of simply tossing this information onto the computer system?

"This... we should keep your powers hidden." Victoria whispered. "Jason... what if the demons learn about this knowledge? They would have a huge tactical advantage."

Jason's smile wavered. He looked away thoughtfully, then shrugged.

"Nah, not possible. The demons are bad with technology, so they won't be able to steal any of the files. Anyway, I also want you to make sure the troops here know about my

abilities so I don't have to explain myself all the time when I talk to them. It would be super tiring if I had to do that constantly."

"Not all demons are ignorant of technology." Victoria hastily explained. "There exists a Baron named Ose. She can hack computer systems. She might be able to find and uncover these files!"

Jason raised an eyebrow. "*Pft. Come on.* Demons are *idiots* with technology. Even if one of them learned a little computer tech stuff, how smart could she possibly be? Worst case scenario, I'll just have to take her down first. She's only a Baron, right? Killing her will be a piece of cake. Besides, the Illuminati has top of the line computer hacking protection, right? So how can one measly Demon Baron compare to humanity's mastery of technology? You're overthinking a mere bloodskin's capabilities."

Victoria swallowed heavily. She felt stifled by Jason's retorts.

Was he an idiot?? Didn't he understand just how big a threat his life would come under if the demons learned of his true powers?!

She didn't know how to change his mind. Internally, her assessment of him fell several points.

How could he be such a dope? Just handing over information like this was kind of him and would help solidify his truthfulness with the Illuminati rank and file, but that was secondary to preserving his life and combat advantage!

Victoria fell silent for a full minute. At one point, a bizarre thought crossed her mind.

Could he be lying about his powers?

Was he deliberately feeding the Illuminati's computers with false information to throw his enemies off? That didn't make any sense though. She had personally seen his abrupt combat mastery with martial weapons. He also possessed knowledge about things he clearly shouldn't. He must have awakened his 'Dream Eating' ability and woke up a completely changed man. Everything fit!

She slowly shook her head, while feeling the heat of Jason's gaze on the side of her face. She didn't know why he was so hellbent on revealing his true powers, but the Ancestors had told her to obey Jason's commands, so...

Victoria swallowed the lump in her throat. With great hesitation, she copied the memory card's files to an internal database, noting that there were new videos of his

powers in action she'd need to review later. While she couldn't understand his idiotic motivations for recording down everything about himself, she was enough of a professional to do her duty.

"Alright. I've transmitted the files to Eliezer." Victoria said, turning to carefully look at Jason's smiling face. She had no idea where he obtained such self-confidence, but already she felt he was not as impressive as she first imagined. "What next?"

Jason squeezed her shoulder reassuringly. "Nothing, for now. Just make sure the next time I come here, I won't have to explain who I am to everyone, and that they all know I'm in charge. Mildred and I have work to do in preparation for the coming weeks."

Victoria nodded. "...As you command."

Jason's thoughts were completely foreign to her, but she assumed he and the Ancestors must have a purpose behind all this. She simply had to hope the wisdom of the predecessors was good enough to guide the foolish young Trueborn on his future path to elevating humanity's status.

* * *

Some time later, Jason, Victoria, and Claire emerged back onto the top level of the Haven. Jason strolled over to his father and smiled.

"All done. Artifacts acquired." Jason said, though he didn't seem to be carrying the artifacts anywhere on his person.

Cat Mask was sitting heavily atop a reinforced steel container filled with weapons. One of the Illuminati's recent deliveries, it seemed. When Jason spoke, Hideki raised his head and peered at his son through his mask's eye-holes.

"Oh, good. That was fast."

Jason scratched his head. Several hours of talking didn't feel 'fast' to him, but it probably was like a blink of an eye to his father.

"Yeah. Let's get going. Once Mildred and I finish, I can return to execute the next phase of the plan."

Victoria, Claire, and the soldiers on base saluted Jason as he and his father left. Now that he was the acting leader of the Illuminati, news of his ascension would spread quickly. Victoria feared what might happen if the demons found out, but he had made his

intentions clear. It was no longer her place to speak against them so long as he had the Illuminator's blessing.

After Jason and Cat Mask departed, Victoria groaned under her breath. "Claire, I *really* hope that Trueborn knows what he's doing."

Claire appeared nonplussed. She looked at her cousin in amusement. Unlike Victoria, Claire had spoken to Jason before Cat Mask took him away. She had gotten a pretty decent feel of the man. While he certainly seemed more confident than before, his personality hadn't changed much, and Claire had already made a crucial guess about his future intentions.

"You seem worried, Victoria." Claire said with an amused look on her face. "There's no need to be. Just do what he says. I think it will all play out exactly how he plans."

Victoria didn't pick up on the hidden implications in her cousin's words. She groaned even more heavily than before. "That's what I'm worried about."

"You'll see." Claire said, her smile brightening a little more. "*You will see*..."

Part 629: 'Papa' Vasily Sokolov

January 15th, 2021. Midnight. Moscow, Russia.

While Jason and Hideki went on a sort of spiritual father-son journey, a young woman silently materialized on the southwestern outskirts of Moscow, far out in the countryside several kilometers from the city center. Daisy Hiro's body flickered into existence instantly, so fast that if a man were to blink his eyes, she would startle him with the suddenness of her arrival.

Daisy still wore her Russian military officer uniform. She was surprised her father hadn't really asked her much about it, but considering he had just regained his memories, he was probably feeling overwhelmed with emotions. Daisy could hardly blame him. She felt a deep sense of surrealism regarding the whole affair too.

Daisy appeared inside a small forested tree-line at the property line of a large mansion. Located near the southern gate of her home, Daisy had been using this particular micro-forest to come and go for years. It was a relatively ordinary-seeming grove, with bushy trees and dense foliage suitable for covering her comings and going. Her 'papa' had taken care to ensure gardeners were never in the area and allowed the trees to grow haphazardly as they wished.

Before making a move, Daisy knelt down and closed her eyes. The world invisibly shimmered around her as she radiated a psyker wave to perceive her surroundings. This pulse of energy mapped out every creature, insect, plant and bird for an entire kilometer in every direction. Once satisfied, she stood up again and looked around warily.

Daisy Hiro was a Hero. She had known this her entire life. She also knew she was a Trueborn. But her existence was extremely secretive. Not even a handful of people knew her true identity, and her 'papa' had always warned her to take extreme precautions when traveling around. Her ability to teleport anywhere on Earth was an amazing power, but it was far from the only one in her toolkit.

Over the years, Daisy had discovered countless layers to her powers. But she also discovered that they changed slowly over time. Some of the abilities she wielded as a 6-year-old no longer worked, while she had then gone on to develop entirely new ones as she aged.

She didn't know why this was the case. Perhaps her powers were innately Chaotic, or perhaps she was a unique type of Hero that did not follow the usual paradigm. As it just so happened, there had been other unique Heroes throughout history who wielded powers outside the ordinary, but they were few and far between. One of the more noteworthy ones was Alexander the Great, who wielded power over time and space, each power individually manifesting within his differently-colored eyes.

Daisy's powers were not just changing over time, though. She found that the more she used them, the stronger they became. When she was a child, she could only teleport a kilometer or so in any given direction. As a young adult, that same ability had grown to encompass the entire Earth.

The same was true of her telepathy. It was a core ability in her toolkit. She always paid attention to the thoughts of others, even when she sometimes wished she couldn't. It allowed her to sniff out people with bad interests in her, and to determine whether or not someone could be trusted. It unfortunately also allowed her to visualize people's disturbing desires, kinks, and other such things; an aspect of her telepathy she desperately wished she could disable.

As Daisy carefully crept out of the forest in the middle of the night, she never let down her guard. She had yet to run into a single demon in her life, but she knew it was possible the demons could track her movements. After all, other humans could. Tracking Heroic Energy was rare, but not terribly difficult, so she had to take great care not to accidentally draw eyes upon her most prolific teleportation areas. This grove in particular was unique, because her papa had brought in specialists to cover the area with energy muffling technology so as to hide Daisy's jaunts around the planet. Daisy wasn't entirely sure how the technology worked, but her papa said it had apparently been developed nearly a hundred years ago, during World War II...

It didn't take the young woman long to make her way over to the edge of the mansion. She sneaked around its edge under the cover of darkness, bypassing several guards who walked around outside, heavily armed, ready to gun down the intruders. Each time one of the guards should have spotted her, he looked right through Daisy, overlooking her existence entirely. This, too, was a powerful trick of her telepathy. She could force weaker-minded entities to look right through her as if she were invisible. She'd used it countless times over the years to sneak out, to her papa's chagrin.

Eventually, Daisy arrived at the front door. She stopped sneaking around, and calmly walked right up the steps, where two armed guards immediately aimed their weapons at her. Despite knowing her face by heart, they took no chances.

"What's your name?" The guard on the right asked.

"No matter if the walls fall, Berlin will always tower over the world." Daisy immediately responded.

Naturally, the guard's question was a trap. If she had responded with her name, he would have gunned her down on the spot, assuming she was Belial or some other shapeshifter. The fact there was a male and female guard also had to do with this, since women were immune to the effects of demonkind's greatest infiltrator.

The guards both lowered their weapons.

"You're back late, Daisy." The female guard said.

"I had business to take care of, Lea." Daisy explained nonchalantly. "Is papa home?"

She hardly had to ask. She could sense her "papa's" presence even through all the walls separating them.

"He is." Lea replied. "I'd say he's worried sick about you, but we all know you'll come home eventually."

Daisy nodded. She strode through the front door, ending the conversation right there.

Daisy knew the names of all the people on the property. She also knew their general backgrounds, their desires and dreams, and whether or not they could be trusted. She even knew a fellow named Boris was stealing cigars from the pantry, but she decided not to rat him out. It was a minor crime, and far be it for her to care if some of those dreadful things went missing. Her 'Papa' already smoked way too much for his own good.

When Daisy entered the manor, she took off her boots and dropped them at the front door, then donned a pair of pink bunny slippers. They looked a little comical when paired with her stodgy military uniform, but she didn't care. These slippers were a present from her first friend after Papa rescued her, so she had been wearing them for years, even going so far as to have a professional seamstress enlarge and repair them so they were better fit for her adult feet.

Daisy's slippers *plapped* against the tiled floor as she headed up the central staircase, ignoring the awe-inspiring sights of all the different men and women painted on murals

hung along the walls. Each of these people were part of her papa's lineage, but they had no blood relation to her, so she didn't particularly care about them.

By the time Daisy made it to the second floor, her loud slippers had drawn someone's attention. A younger girl in a wheelchair rolled over to the top of the stairwell and smiled tiredly. "Daisy... you're back...!"

"Anya, what are you doing up this late?" Daisy hissed, putting on a mock show of irritation. "You're supposed to be in bed!"

Anya feebly smiled. Her medium-length dark black hair partially hid her eyes due to her unkempt bangs, and this added to her feeble appearance. She had been sick and infirm her entire life. Daisy might have once been able to cure her, but after those terrible experiments the scientists performed on her, her healing abilities had been one of the first powers she lost.

"I knew you'd be back late..." Anya said, slowly wheeling over to Daisy. "Hug."

Daisy grinned. She knelt down and gently took her adopted sister in her arms, then lifted her slightly to give her a big, warm hug.

"Oh, Anya. You really need your rest." Daisy said, after setting her little sister back in her wheelchair. "You can't be waiting up for me like this."

"It's not like I have anything else to do." Anya muttered, lowering her eyes. "Daddy never lets me go anywhere."

Daisy winced. Her little sister's immune system was badly compromised. Going outside might as well be a death sentence. Some of the best doctors in the world had paid Anya a visit, but nobody had made any significant progress on her disease. It was a new strain, something a few even whispered may have originated from the demons...

"Anya..." Daisy said, kneeling down to her sister's level. "I... I finally went to see him today. My dad. He remembered me!"

Anya's eyes widened. "He did? But I thought you said...?"

"Yeah, I never thought he would remember, but things changed today. A lot. It's all still a whirlwind. It seems my dad time-traveled too! But my mom... oh, it's such a long story..."

Since the two girls were as close as blood sisters, Daisy only hesitated for a moment before opting to tell Anya everything, or at least almost everything. She told her about

Jason's time in the future, the destruction of an entire planet, and his eventual rewinding back in time. Then she told Anya about her father's powers.

"See? My dad is really awesome!" Daisy explained. "I bet I can have him come here and heal you."

"You really think so?" Anya asked, her eyes turning watery. "I don't... have to stay... a cripple?"

"Don't say that. You're not a cripple!" Daisy protested. "You're my cute little sister!"

Anya appeared unmoved. "Easy for you to say. You get to leave whenever you want..."

Her words hit Daisy like a gut punch. For a brief moment, Daisy felt a deep pain inside her stomach, and she had to look away. It didn't help that she could practically feel a surge of resentment under Anya's emotions.

Anya was only 12 years old, but she had spent the majority of her life in a wheelchair, only able to leave if her father gave permission. Unable to go to a regular school. Forced to watch as her 'big sister', the family favorite, flitted around the world doing amazing things Anya couldn't dream of.

It gave Daisy a sense of guilt as deep as the ocean.

"Alright Anya." Daisy said, looking away as she forced her emotions back down. "I'll get my dad to come here as soon as he can. Okay? I want to get you out of that chair."

Anya reached up and pulled on Daisy's sleeve. "Big sis... I didn't... I didn't mean to say that. I'm sorry. I didn't mean it."

"It's okay," Daisy said, turning back to force a smile at her. "Big sis will make it all better. Alright? Just wait a little longer."

Anya nodded. "Okay."

After a few more minutes of talking, Daisy flicked her gaze down the hallway. "Ivan's asleep. Mikhail too. You're the only one who waited up for me, huh?"

"Of course!" Anya said, her spirits lifting slightly. "I have to keep an eye out for you!"

The two of them concluded their talk, and Daisy wheeled Anya back to her room. After saying farewell, Daisy turned and headed back down the main hall on the second floor. Eventually, she arrived before a large, imposing door.

Daisy swallowed heavily. Then she pressed her hands against it, and opened it up.

She arrived inside a fire-lit living room with two luxurious sofas angled toward the fire. These sofas had red velvet covers and gold plated edging, making them appear very expensive and luxurious. Above, a chandelier offered additional illumination inside the room, though it was set to low lighting to preserve the night-time ambiance.

Finally, off to the left side of the room, there was a rather large mahogany desk littered with papers. A massive man sat in his executive chair, his short black hair and aged face making him look extremely intimidating to those who knew nothing about him.

On the desk there sat a nameplate made of wood, with gold etchings revealing the man's name: Vasily Sokolov.

"Papa, I'm back!" Daisy said, beaming a bright smile at him.

"Daisy, Daisy, so good to see you back." Vasily said, before pushing his chair back and slowly standing up. He stretched for a moment to crack his back, then he exhaled in relief and sauntered around the desk, walking over to Daisy's side.

Without hesitation, Daisy dove into his arms to give him a big hug. In their family, hugs were very important, allowing others to forgive and forget grudges, as well as preserve their emotional bonds.

"What sort of mischief have you been up to, da?" The mountain of a man asked. He turned to the nearest couch and sat down, sagging into its embrace, while Daisy chose to sit next to him. He put an arm around his adopted daughter's shoulder while she proceeded to detail her day.

"I went to see my father again." Daisy explained. "Remember I told you he was a Hero like me? Well, he awakened his Heroic Powers, and now it turns out he also sent his mind back in time. He time traveled, just like me!"

Vasily smiled at her. "Is that so? Then you are a Trueborn, and so is he?"

Daisy nodded excitedly. "That's right. And my father's powers are incredible too. He's even more powerful than me!"

"Da, is good then, is good." Vasily said, before using his free hand to reach into his pocket. He pulled out a large Cuban cigar, stuck in it his mouth, then retracted his arm from around Daisy's shoulder to pull a lighter out of his pocket. Daisy's expression darkened. She hastily stood up and moved to the other couch, giving Vasily a disgusted look.

"Papa! Must you smoke when I am around? You know I hate those!"

Vasily hesitated for a moment. But then, he simply shrugged. He lit the cigar up anyway, puffing on it while blowing the smoke away from her.

"Little Daisy, a man must have his vices, da? Now tell me about your father. Is it okay for me to finally learn the name of the man who brought you into this world?"

Daisy's smile faltered. She tried to read Vasily's mind, but she knew it was a pointless endeavor. Over the years, her papa's mental fortitude had grown by leaps and bounds. Perhaps due to being in her orbit so often, he had slowly developed an ability known as the Mind of Void. Telepaths could not read his thoughts, and that included Daisy herself. She used to be able to, but over time, this divide had put a bit of distance between her and her papa.

"I... I don't know." Daisy said, lowering her eyes.

"You do not trust me." Vasily stated, looking neither annoyed nor bothered by this statement. "Little one, I do not wish to hurt your father. He is Trueborn Hero like you, da? Then he is in great danger. What if demons find him? Or angels? Or Titans? What if United State Fascists find him? They do experiments on him, da? Do you think I want this to happen? I saved you from same evildoers, da?"

Daisy's expression fell further. She squirmed a little in her seat, not sure of what to say.

For years, despite proclaiming that she was a time traveler and that she had a father in this time, she had never actually told anyone his name. Since she was captured and experimented on by Russian scientists immediately after arriving in this timeline, she feared they might go after and hurt her father.

Even after being rescued by Vasily Sokolov and growing to care about him, Daisy still forced herself never to tall anyone her father's name. She had, naturally, located him when she was only ten years old, but she was always extremely careful about visiting him in person so he would never recognize her. She also didn't want to visit him too often, lest she accidentally draw eyeballs to his position. That was one reason she took so many jaunts around the globe; to obfuscate her true intentions and mask the important places she was traveling.

She hadn't told Anya her father's true name, let alone Vasily. Doing so now felt like... a betrayal of sorts.

Vasily waved his cigar. "Never mind, little one. Is not important. You spoke to your father, da? And he is good?"

Daisy nodded slowly. "Yes. He regained his memories from the future, and can use his powers again. But I can't tell anyone what his powers are unless he says it's okay."

"I would not ask." Vasily said, waving his hand flippantly. "Daisy, look at me. I want only for you to have happy. Understand? I hope that in time, you will bring your father here. It would be good to show him the strength of mighty Russia, da? I assume he is dog of the British or America, da? Expanding his viewpoint could benefit humanity greatly."

Daisy frowned. Considering how many times her blood had been drawn as a child, it was perfectly reasonable that someone could link her genetic markers to her father, Jason. At the very least, finding out her ancestry wasn't a difficult task, especially given how many public websites offered to trace genetic ancestries these days.

"He... is American, yes." Daisy said slowly. "But I don't think my father holds any particular allegiance to the United States."

"I hope so." Vasily replied smoothly. "Our 'Great Leader' has his faults, but he has better head on his shoulders than those soulless, western pigs. They go in and out of power every four years, da, but Russia is superpower who slowly builds and accumulates power in one great leader until time to pass off duties to the next in line. When time is right, if we add you and your father to our ranks, Mother Russia will rise to heights never seen by any other country!"

"Papa..." Daisy said slowly. "This... the situation has changed. There's something you need to know."

Vasily frowned. He looked at his adopted daughter, his 'niece' as he referred to her, and sat up a little straighter.

"Something is the matter?" Vasily asked.

"I don't think I can be worried about stuff like 'countries', based on the storm that's coming." Daisy explained. "You see, there's... there's a..."

Daisy hesitated. It wasn't that she was unwilling to tell her uncle, but that she worried this information could be intercepted. Her uncle was a well-known public figure, one of

the ten core Russian politicians serving under its President. It was quite possible someone had bugged the house. Not to mention, if there was even a chance a Psion were listening in, it could be game over for humanity...

Daisy bit her lip. She looked around the room, then closed her eyes and spread out her senses.

Instantly, a spherical wall spread out of her mind, engulfing the entire manor in a net of psychic investigatory powers. Daisy swept every inch of the manor, intentionally sending pulses of energy out to disable countless electrical-based devices, including objects she suspected were listening devices, cameras, and other such things. She wasn't a technology-focused psyker, so she couldn't be entirely sure what she was disabling, but she could always have her papa fix the devices later if necessary.

After two long minutes, Daisy opened her eyes. The lights in the room had gone out, leaving her and Vasily bathed only in the fireplace's light. He looked up at the chandelier, which had lost power a minute before, and seemed to realize something.

"Something serious, child?"

Daisy nodded slowly. She couldn't know if anyone was still listening in, but she had to tell her uncle anyway.

"It's like this, Papa... there are aliens out there, beyond Earth's orbit. They are called *Volgrim*, and are part of a civilization that controls the entire galaxy. As we speak, there are millions of them living on Earth, wearing human faces... but they are not human at all. They are Changelings. And even more frighteningly, Changelings are the weakest and most benign of the five Volgrim subspecies..."

Daisy spoke for a long period of time. The more she talked, the colder Vasily's expression became. A look of shock passed over his face, then faded into a solemn expression of duty.

"Is good you have told me this, child." Vasily said, some thirty minutes later. His cigar turned cherry red as he inhaled deeply through it. "Now, many things I once suspected to be foul play make *so* much more sense. Hmm... it will take me time to think about these matters. I must keep mouth shut, not inform people carelessly. And you believe these 'Volgrim' may be listening in now?"

"I hope they aren't." Daisy whispered. "But... I can't say for certain."

"Let us pray they are not." Vasily replied. "If this dark future comes to pass, humanity will need every additional day to prepare. Mother Russia will play a *key* role in preparing for that future..."

Author notes:

This is Vasily Sokolov's artwork

I have also gone back and added [Daisy Hiro and Hideki Hiro's artwork to Part 622](). [HFY Link](). I should have added it from the start, but I got sloppy!

Part 630: Road Trip

January 19th, 2021. 8AM. Portland, Oregon.

The receptionist at Cryotek, Leeta, sat down to type up a manifest report on all the visitors from the day before. This was a typical morning task, nothing out of the ordinary, and something she had done a thousand times. Having worked at Cryotek for three years, she had yet to move up in the organization, but she also wasn't trying to, either. Working here was great because it was a part-time job that offered stable hours while she attended classes at the University of Portland.

As Leeta rapidly typed up a list, she paused to look around the lobby. There was only one person here, this early in the morning, and he was just some businessman waiting for an assessment appointment for a future entry into the second or third round of cryo-storage, assuming the first round went well. Unfortunately, due to delays forced by the recent arrest of that Jason Hiro terrorist guy, Cryotek had faced increased government scrutiny and put off its first batch of cryogenic freezing for a few weeks. A lot of people were angry, but through some carefully worded emails the company was able to squeak by with minimal blowback.

Still, Leeta was annoyed. She had planned to enjoy several weeks off once the company shut down future sign-ups to monitor the first batch of participants. It would be at least two or three more weeks until she enjoyed her impromptu vacation.

As she sat there, typing at over a hundred words per minute and sulking in the back of her mind, the main doors opened, and a muscular man wearing a black suit, sunglasses, and a wide-brimmed hat walked in. He glanced around the lobby, then looked at Leeta before heading toward her. Leeta pushed her annoyance aside and beamed a smile at him.

"Good morning, sir. Do you have an appointment?"

The man didn't smile back. He reached into his back pocket and pulled out his wallet, then flashed a badge at her.

"Agent Ryan Lederman, South Carolina Special Division. I'm here today to ask some questions regarding the recent arrest of a young man inside Cryotek. Could you direct me to someone in charge?"

Leeta blinked. "Of course. Rebecca Langley is our head researcher. She should have access to that information, and clearance to answer your questions."

The man frowned slightly. "Mmm. Is there, perhaps, a man in charge?"

Leeta couldn't help herself. Her smile deflated instantly.

Of COURSE this *asshole* had to be some big macho tough guy misogynist. It was clear he thought women couldn't lead or do anything themselves. Guys like this were the bane of every woman's existence, and it was obvious just by looking at him he was some meathead who thought only men could run businesses. Leeta was tempted to immediately call Rebecca out, have her give him a piece of her mind, but Leeta thought better of it. She decided to just ignore his misogyny and resist the urge to roll her eyes.

"...We have Doctor Reginald in the back. He's the other Head Researcher, but-"

"That's fine." Ryan said, looking around the lobby. "As long as it's a man. Don't really have time to chit-chat about nails and whatever."

Leeta nearly blew a fuse. She had to fight against the demons in her heart lest she explode in rage at this piece of work, and it took all her self control to silently press the button on her phone system, dial Head Researcher Reginald's office, and ask him through gritted teeth if he had time to speak to this *fine upstanding gentleman*. Luckily, Reginald came out and ushered Ryan into his office before Leeta lost her temper.

This time, when Leeta returned to tapping on the keyboard, her fingers impacted the keys with the angry force of a jackhammer. Even the businessman in the suit across the lobby glanced at her, noticing how much louder her typing had become as she deliberately vented her anger on the keyboard.

Not twenty minutes later, Agent Ryan exited the office. He walked past Leeta without saying a word, as if the existence of a woman had disappeared from his mind once she was out of sight and mind.

"Have. A. Nice. Day." Leeta said, biting the words off at him as he strode toward the front door.

Ryan didn't even pause. "Yeah, thanks."

* * *

Outside, Ryan walked away from the Cryotek building in a calm and measured manner. After walking down a few side streets, he turned into a coffee shop and sat down,

taking off his sunglasses and pressing his finger to his lips.

"Hmm. So his name was Jason Hiro. Assigned to cryosleep through a randomized clinical trial. Expressed interest in quitting the program, according to what Seymour told me. The security cameras showed a plain black truck took him, but they didn't look government-issued. Certainly not FBI. The MO doesn't match the Knights Templar. That leaves the Illuminati. Damn. They must have taken the kid to their base out east. But why? To what end?"

Ryan chewed his nail for a few minutes, mulling various thoughts in his mind.

"...There's no other choice. I have to infiltrate their base. But I'm a known asset. They probably have men and women mixed together in and out of uniform. Cameras everywhere. Security precautions and alarms and other human tech I won't understand. It won't be as easy as it was just twenty or thirty years ago. I can't keep up with the humans' rate of advancements these days..."

'Ryan' closed his eyes and massaged his forehead.

"Two options. I either try to sneak in quietly, or I go the loud route. The Illuminati is formidable, and they can definitely beat back a single Emperor with the options at their disposal, but the problem is the kid. *Jason Hiro*. Come on, the name itself seems to imply... no, wouldn't that be too on the nose? Hiro? *Hero*? Could he be a Trueborn? Did his parents have an ironic naming sense, or was it just karma and luck or something? Bah, it's going to be a serious problem if he *is* a Hero. Satan will not be happy."

"So if I go in loud, maybe they evacuate Jason with some underground route. Even if I knock everyone out, he might be long gone. Not to mention, if they picked him up, they must have detected his Heroic Energy. Maybe he's already started using his powers. What abilities does he have? Is he a weakling, or a powerhouse?"

As it turned out, this 'Agent Ryan' was merely one of Belial's casual disguises. She didn't even bother looking up a real government agency. By the time anyone figured out someone unauthorized had viewed the security cameras, she would be long gone, and all the blame would be pinned on Head Researcher Reginald. Poor guy might even get fired, not that she cared.

"I shouldn't approach this mission alone." Belial muttered to herself, remaining in her 'secret agent' disguise. "I need backup. When it comes to bypassing human tech, there's only one valid option. It has to be Ose. She's a bit bratty, but she's reliable when it comes

to this stuff. I should also bring along... yeah, that would work. Just in case things go badly and we need to get loud. It's always good to have a backup option."

A waitress approached Belial. "Excuse me sir, would you like any coffee?"

"Fuck off." Belial said, not even bothering to look at the woman.

"Ah! Well, fine then, asshole. Jesus." The waitress said, storming away in a huff.

It wasn't that Belial was usually rude to women, but just in case she was being followed, she needed to maintain her disguise. This persona of 'Ryan Lederman' was a misogynist who only talked to men, so it was best if she always ignored and downplayed women when opportunities arose.

Belial sat for a while longer, formulating a plan. Then, she stood up, walked out, and waved for a taxi.

January 19th, 2020. 2PM. Seattle, Washington.

"Big Brian! Ahhh!!! I'm SUCH a huge fan! You're soooo hot!!!"

A woman screamed in glee as her favorite rockstar walked past, a mountain of a man wearing a black leather jacket seemingly taken right out of an 80's rock band. The man proudly stomped forward, his giant feet leaving faint imprints on the floor as he maneuvered his eight-foot-tall frame around the back halls of the concert area. Big Brian shot the woman a goofy smile and nodded. "Well shucks, thanks for the compliment, toots! You ain't lookin' so bad yourself!"

He gave the woman a huge thumbs up, and she screamed in delight even louder. Next to the woman were hundreds of other people, all held behind a short fence to keep them from rushing the A-list celebrity. Big Brian had been on a comeback tour along with some of his old bandmates, as well as a few new faces. Naturally, while most of the fanbase was on the 40+ side of the age curve, there were still some younger fans who also thought he was cool in a way only people of an older generation could be.

Camera's whirred and clicked, bathing Big Brian and his bandmates in a series of white flashes. Behind him, Shatter and Screamer walked, a longtime brother and sister duo who were getting up there in years, yet still seemed to age extremely gracefully. Screamer in particular looked as attractive as many modern twenty-year old performers, seeming as if she hadn't aged a day. She wore black lipstick and had a somewhat gothic

appearance, but her moodiness didn't deter an avalanche of men from constantly sending her fanmail.

Shatter on the other hand sported a huge head of frizzy white hair. He constantly stuck his tongue out and made crazy faces at the nearby fans as he walked, shouting his iconic catch phrases like "Shatter the heavens!!" and "Burn us down to hell!!"

As they strode past the fans, their security detail kept a careful watch out. One could never be too sure if some psycho would threaten the talent's lives, and there was always the danger of a smuggled handgun or an explosive that could bring tragedy to an otherwise positive event.

Eventually, the performers left the concert hall, went backstage, and entered their dressing rooms. Big Brian cracked his back after they closed the door and secured the area.

"Ohh, man! That was a great concert, Shax! You were on fire tonight!"

"You too, Bael!" Shax laughed back. "You beat those drums like your life depended on it. I was having trouble keeping up with you!"

The trio touched their rings and reverted their false human appearances, revealing their demonic forms. Bael, Shax, and Murmur regained their red skin, feeling no different than when their disguises were activated. Still, they preferred to be in their demon forms, since that felt a little more natural.

"Murmur, you doin' okay?" Bael asked, leaning down to her level. "You're a little quieter than usual."

Murmur levitated on top of her big brother's shoulder. She was extremely short, less than three feet tall to her brother's seven foot stature. Their heights didn't change when in human form, so it was a distinct contrast that helped make their band look unique, even in simple silhouettes on promotional material.

"It's nothing." Murmur said quietly. "Just... a creepy guy. Kept calling me 'little girl.' I didn't like it."

Bael's smile soured. "What? So there was some punk thinkin' weird thoughts? What he look like? I'll straighten him right out!"

Murmur crossed her arms and looked away. "I'll do it myself. Later. Just not in the mood right now."

"Oh. Okay." Bael said, lowering his fists. "Well, look, I'm pretty hungry. Whaddya guys say we go get some Mexican food, huh?"

While it was true that demons often *enjoyed* eating the flesh of humans, as it happened, human food was so delicious that many demons opted to try out their cuisine occasionally, or even regularly. Bael was one of the more prolific cases.

"I'm not in the mood for any food." Shax said. "I'm gonna go nap for a bit. My throat's kinda worn out, man."

Murmur shrugged. "I'll go."

"Hell yeah!" Bael said. "Let's go, Murmur! Food time! Food time! Food time!"

Murmur levitated off Shax's shoulder, then fiddled with her ring to return to her human appearance. She looked like a dwarf human, but also sort of like a cute little girl in her teens, albeit much shorter than the average. After Bael reverted back to his human state, the two of them headed into their personal changing areas to swap clothing. Bael donned a giant black T-shirt with a skull and crossbones on the front, while Murmur ended up putting on a simple black sundress. She didn't like dressing up, and always opted to wear rather basic clothing when out and about.

After the duo finished changing clothes, Bael took Murmur's hand, and the two of them left the dressing room, flanked by their security. In order not to draw much attention, they first surveyed a path without fans, sneaked out the back, and got inside a black SUV. Their driver drove them over to a Mexican restaurant, and allowed them to leave, alone. Naturally, bodyguards surveyed the perimeter, but they made sure to give Bael and Murmur space so they wouldn't attract attention inside. They had no way of knowing that a random psycho with a gun had zero chance of causing these two any harm, but they still had to make sure their assigned talents stayed safe.

After entering the restaurant, Bael squeezed his huge body into a small chair, while Murmur sat opposite him, her head barely able to peek over the table. She blushed slightly out of embarrassment before asking for a booster seat. But then again, she was used to having to do this.

"Alright," Bael said, after looking at the menu for five minutes. "Waiter guy! I'll take a plate of this stuff, this stuff, this soupy stuff, this, this, three of these, and... you know what? This looks good too. What about you, *Screamer*?"

Murmur handed the menu back to the waiter. "A plate of fajitas for me."

The waiter took their order, then gave Bael a long, serious look. He alone had just ordered more than $400 worth of food. Was he seriously going to eat it all? Maybe they had more friends on the way.

But the waiter decided not to question anything. "Si, senor. Give us ten minutes for the Fajitas, and... do you want all your food at once, senor?"

"Nah, just bring it out as you cook it." Bael said. "I'll be eating for a while."

"Oh. Alright then, you are the boss, senor." The waiter said, before walking away scratching his head and muttering something under his breath.

Naturally, Bael and Murmur heard his muttered words, but they didn't care. He was just some unimportant human. His opinions didn't matter at all.

Murmur looked around the restaurant. Surprisingly, she and Bael were the only people there, despite being in the middle of the day on a Sunday. It was rather bizarre. Maybe the restaurant wasn't doing too well financially and would soon go out of business? She had no idea.

While they waited for their food to arrive, Bael smiled at her.

"Somethin's on your mind, I can tell." Bael said. "Hit me. What's up?"

Murmur lowered her eyes. She sighed.

"Bael... I..."

She paused.

"First, promise not to tell Shax. Not yet."

Bael's smile slipped. "Uh... sure. But why not?"

Murmur's toes fidgeted under the table.

"Because... I... want to quit the band."

Bael's jaw dropped. "W-what? No way! You're kiddin'. Why, Murmur? You've got the voice of an angel."

"I only sing because Shax likes it." Murmur muttered. "But *I* don't like singing. I like being around Shax. He's always there. He makes me feel safe. But this whole... band thing. We've been doing it for so long. I'm tired of it. I want to do something else."

Bael looked at her, crestfallen. "Come on, sister. Whaddya mean? What else could you possibly wanna do?"

Murmur didn't immediately answer. She fell silent as the waiter returned with her plate of fajitas, as well as Bael's first entree, which turned out to be three gigantic burritos covered in red sauce and onions.

After the waiter left, Murmur speared some of her veggies and meat. She silently bit into the delicious fajitas, savoring their hot and crispy texture while giving herself time to think.

"I'm not sure." She eventually said, answering Bael's previous question. "Maybe... painting? I want to try painting."

Bael nodded. He shoved part of the first burrito in his mouth and took a huge bite, horking down a third of it instantly. Red sauce ran down his face, but he didn't notice. He chewed loudly in a lip-smacking manner that would disgust most people, but which Murmur had long grown used to, then he finished off the rest of the burrito in two more bites.

"Mmm! I mean, painting's cool. It's cool!" Bael said, being surprisingly careful not to spit burrito debris all over Murmur's side of the table. "You think you'll be any good??"

"I don't know." Murmur said, her voice lowering slightly. "It's not about 'being good' for me. I just think it would be fun. More fun than singing. I don't like singing. I just don't know how to tell Shax. He's... he's going to feel so sad. I don't want to make him sad."

Bael paused his eating. He noticed a hint of depression on Murmur's face. It slowly sunk into his thick skull that this situation wasn't as simple as he previously thought.

Slowly, very very slowly, the gears of something approaching 'thoughts' whirred inside Bael's head. He looked at Murmur with slightly glazed eyes, trying to think of something smart to say.

Then, like a bolt of lightning, it hit him! The perfect response!

"Ehh, he'll get over it." Bael said, waving his hand flippantly. "It ain't that big a deal. We're demons. You can always come back someday. Do another tour. You just do your painting, girl. Don't let nobody tell you otherwise!"

Murmur frowned. She daintily ate another forkful of peppers and steak.

"But... Shax loves when I sing." Murmur said, looking at Bael with hopeful eyes. "How can we break the news to him?"

"Maaan, you're overthinking this." Bael said, rolling his eyes. "Seriously, it ain't no big deal, Murmur. Look, we just find another demon girl who likes singing, yeah? We'll just say you're retirin' or whatever, say we got a new talent lined up, boom! Easy! Besides, you gonna go live somewhere else?"

Murmur slowly shook her head. "No... I'll still be here."

"Great! Then you'll come to the concerts?"

She nodded again. "Yes..."

"Then what's the problem??" Bael asked. "You ain't fallin' off the face of the Earth! You'll just be chillin' in the dressing room, paintin' up a storm. Easy. We'll miss havin' ya on stage, but you can always come back if the paintin' thing don't work out."

"Oh." Murmur said, smiling shyly. "I guess I was overthinking things. Not much is going to change. Thanks, Bael. You're such a smart guy."

Bael snorted. "Let's not go *too* far now."

The door to the Mexican restaurant opened. Murmur turned her head in the direction of the man who entered, then frowned. He wore a black suit, sunglasses, and a wide-brimmed hat, but secretly, she felt a mild current of demonic energy thanks to a resonance spike within her own disguise ring.

The man walked over to their table, and Bael lifted his head, only now noticing the new arrival.

"The hell? Don't even THINK of touching my food, pal!" Bael snapped, giving this newcomer a mean look.

"I'm not interested in your food, Bael." The man said, before turning to Murmur and winking.

"Hey Murmur. Since you're here, guess I can invite you as well. Would you two like to go on a little... *road trip*?"

Part 631: Ose's Revelation

January 20th, 2021. 9PM.

A full day passed, plus several extra hours. Belial, Bael, and Murmur had to use several secret demon transfer locations to meet up with Warpers hiding among the humans. By doing so, they were able to jump around the USA until they finally arrived in northern California, nearly a thousand kilometers from where they started in Seattle, Washington.

But eventually, they did arrive. Bael grumbled to himself. He yawned and scratched his ass, but kept his complaints to a minimum as he dutifully followed Belial toward the edge of Crescent City, at the tip-top northwestern corner of the state. It wasn't a big city, with a population well under 10,000, but it was strategically located along the western US coastline, and was within spitting distance of the state border; useful for all sorts of demonic activities.

The woods east of the city opened up to reveal the roads and houses at the city's edge, but Belial didn't travel any further. Instead, she, Bael, and Murmur all came to a stop just inside the treeline, then they stood still and waited.

Eventually, the ground opened up. A Burrower Demon Grunt emerged from the topsoil, looked around, then quickly bowed.

"Emperor Belial. Emperor Murmur. Duke Bael."

"Rise." Belial said. "Take us to her."

"Of course." The Burrower replied, smoothly standing up and assuming a casual but respectful posture. "Baron Ose is always busy, but she is willing to hear you out."

Belial crinkled her nose. "I'll bet she is."

The Burrower waved his hands. The hole in the ground expanded, and he walked down into the angled hole, while the other three followed him. After walking fifty feet underground, the Burrower sealed the topsoil, taking care to disperse the grass back the way it was minutes before. Not even the most eagle-eyed of angels would notice the disturbance unless they were specifically looking for it, or perhaps if they were attuned with the element of Earth, such as Archangel Uriel once was.

Pitch-black darkness engulfed the demons. Nobody complained. Demons had extremely powerful eyesight, and were able to adjust to rapid changes in luminosity, particularly when it involved darkness. Naturally, extremely bright light could injure them, but they were never worried about walking into dimly lit caves.

The Burrower silently dug a tunnel, traveling down a pre-chosen underground path as he led his superiors to the designated meeting area. Eventually, the path downward opened up into a hallway illuminated with glowing rocks made of magical Sulphurite. This type of element was not a naturally occurring rock, but a type of demoncursed exotic mineral used to illuminate underground passages indefinitely without requiring or draining oxygen the way torches would.

The trio walked ahead, while the Burrower remained behind. Before long, Belial's eyes twitched. She sensed a previously hidden demonic aura emerge up ahead, one she never enjoyed encountering in person.

"Belial! So nice of you to pay me your respects." A female voice said up ahead.

Belial rounded the corner and came face-to-face with one of the demonesses she detested most; none other than Lucifer, the Emperor of Providence.

Lucifer's third eye looked up, down, left and right. It constantly swept the area, watching out for hostiles and penetrating the bedrock with contemptuous ease. At the same time, Lucifer's two ordinary eyes fixated on Belial, making her feel that typical sense of revulsion she always did when encountering a rival Emperor.

"Cut the crap." Belial said, before stopping to cross her arms. "Where's Ose?"

Inside this underground entry chamber, there was a sacrificial pit filled with the bodies of recently murdered and mutilated humans. Belial couldn't help but look at them, her lip twitching in disgust. Lucifer was up to some horrible things, no doubt. But she was also the ruler of the Third Hell of Blood. That made her an equal to Belial, as agreed upon by the Seven Ancient Emperors.

Belial wasn't allowed to interfere with Lucifer's matters unless they directly threatened the interests of demonkind. At the same time, neither was she allowed to scoop up any 'assets' Lucifer employed without the Emperor of Providence's permission.

That would make this next part... difficult.

"Not even a polite 'hello'? Your manners are *dreadful* these days." Lucifer said, her tongue snaking between her razor-sharp teeth as she spoke. When she smiled, it truly made the other conversation participants feel uneasy.

Belial fell silent for a moment. She inhaled a quiet breath, though not quiet enough for Lucifer to overlook.

"A new Trueborn Hero may have arisen." Belial said. "This affects all demons, yourself included. I need Ose's help to infiltrate the Illuminati."

Lucifer's smile disappeared. She looked at Belial with a severe expression.

"That isn't possible." Lucifer stated emphatically. "Harold Whittaker was the last Trueborn. The Nazis ruined the Heroic Aura with their clumsy experiments. There will never be another Trueborn again."

"You and I both know that's not the whole truth." Belial said, narrowing her eyes. "I've heard rumors that the humans have been detecting Heroic energy signatures for the past decade or so. We weren't able to confirm them, but now we can. The Illuminati swept up a young man named Jason Hiro from a place in Oregon called Cryotek Labs, and-"

"What was that?" Lucifer asked, narrowing her eyes. "You expect me to believe the new Trueborn's name is Jason *Hiro*? Can there really be such a coincidence, or did his mother have a sense of humor when she named him?"

"I thought it was silly myself." Belial said, rolling her eyes. "For all I know, this might be an elaborate ruse by the Illuminati. They might have set a trap to take out a few high-ranking demons, like me. If so, I'd be walking blindly into it. But you and I both know I *have* to take that gamble. A humanity with a Hero and without one are two *very* different concepts."

Lucifer fell silent.

She looked at Belial for a few long seconds, then her third eye abruptly snapped onto Belial's face, and a pulse of energy surged into the Emperor of Passion's brain.

"Aargh!" Belial shrieked, taking a step back. "You DARE?!"

She snapped her fist at Lucifer, but the Emperor of Providence ducked the attack with fluid ease, seeing right through Belial's movements. She fired a powerful kinetic energy blast from her third eye, and it smashed into Belial, sending her flying backward until she hit the wall and rattled the underground chamber.

"Lucifer!!" Belial roared, her eyes glowing with hatred.

"Wait! I was just testing you. Peace, Belial." Lucifer shouted, holding up her palms. "I had to know!"

Belial was about to pounce at Lucifer and start ripping her apart. She had wanted to do so for a long time anyway, and this unprovoked attack would have given her the perfect excuse! Unfortunately, with Lucifer abruptly backing down and apologizing, Belial was left flat-footed and unsure of how to respond.

"Had to know about WHAT?!" Belial shouted back. "You've got five seconds before I bring this entire chamber down on both of us!"

"I wasn't sure if you were 'you'." Lucifer explained. "For all I knew, this was an elaborate human ruse to get me to lower my guard. I had to make sure you were really *Belial* and not some advanced clone or robotic mimic. My daughter has warned me such creatures may be invented by humanity soon."

What a great excuse! How wonderful indeed!

Belial gnashed her teeth. In truth, Lucifer's attacks hadn't hurt all that much. If she had intended to fight to the death or to cause severe injuries, Lucifer could have poured far more demonic energy into her initial sneaky strike and Belial would have suffered much more.

"Well... are you *satisfied*?" Belial hissed, standing up straight and looking at Lucifer with eyes that could bore holes in concrete.

Behind Belial, Murmur looked on in concern, but Bael seemed as if he were about to fall asleep. Why would he care about two broads catfighting? He had more important things to think about, like his next meal.

"I am." Lucifer said, folding her hands behind her back. She smiled smugly at Belial. "Well, alright. Even if this Hero stuff is all a bunch of nonsense, it's better to be safe than sorry. I'll take you to Ose. It's up to her if she wants to join you, though."

Without further ado, Lucifer spun on her heels. She trotted past the bodies of the mutilated human corpses, while Belial and the rest forced themselves not to look. Actually, Bael didn't care one way or the other. He'd seen so many ripped-up bodies, it was like looking at pieces of paper laying on the ground. Meaningless to him.

This underground region turned out to be far larger than it first appeared. As Belial and the others walked behind Lucifer, they passed tens, dozens, and hundreds of other low and mid-ranking demons. Hidden under Crescent City, a huge underground crystal mine lurked, with blue and red crystals embedded in the walls, providing light to the areas around them, as well as providing a way of storing demonic energy externally, like batteries. The purpose of all that demonic energy was made clear as they eventually arrived inside a huge underground dome filled with what Belial thought were human-made computers, yet ones that distinctly possessed a demonic aura to their aesthetics. Even a tech-illiterate like her could tell no humans had been involved in the making of these giant servers and CPU-banks.

At the center of the area, a white-haired beauty stood, her eyes glazed over as strings of electrical energy surged out in a hundred different directions, tapping into the computers to achieve some end Belial had no way of understanding.

"Ose. Ose, darling!" Lucifer called out, before stopping fifty meters from the end of the supercomputer cluster. "I have brought guests to see you!"

Belial wiped her forehead. The room was hot. *Really* hot. Demons could deal with high and low temperatures just fine, and even 150F Fahrenheit would only make her sweat a bit, but she had to admit it was truly sweltering in here. The computer cluster ran hot, and while there appeared to be powerful ventilation shafts secreted inside the walls, venting the excess heat outside, they couldn't be too numerous or too expansive, lest the vents draw negative attention from outside observers. Thus, the room was not nearly at a temperature Belial would consider comfortable.

Surprisingly, Ose did not appear negatively impacted by the high heat. Bael was immune to temperature of essentially all sorts, but Ose was a bit different. Her affinity to electricity was also an affinity to energy, and heat was merely an alternate expression of that affinity. As such, high and low temperatures didn't bother her in the slightest, barring the most extreme examples.

Hearing her mother call out, Ose momentarily shifted her mental focus away from the computer cluster. She directed a short glance at Belial and the others then turned back to what she was doing.

"What is it?" Ose asked. "What do they want?"

Belial frowned. Ose was only a Baron, yet she always acted high and mighty; likely the result of her mother constantly telling her how amazing she was. She had an ego nearly as big as Lucifer's, and she never bothered to respect other people's authority.

"I need your help." Belial said, taking a step forward, but stopping at the same position as Lucifer. If Lucifer didn't want to step too close to the computer cluster, there was probably a good reason why, and Belial wasn't about to make a fool of herself by crossing that boundary. "I have reason to believe there might be a human Trueborn somewhere on Earth. I need your help investigating the situation."

Ose remained silent. She continued vacantly gazing into some unknown internal computer matrices, seemingly ignoring Belial's words.

"Hello?" Belial asked, her annoyance growing by the second.

"So you finally figured it out." Ose said, her tone bland. "Took you long enough."

Belial blinked. Lucifer blinked, too.

"You knew?" Belial asked.

"You knew??" Lucifer repeated, slightly aghast. "Ose! Why did you not say anything?"

"I've been monitoring the situation for the better part of a decade." Ose replied. "What do you think this computer network is? It's a spynet I built to wiretap every advanced computer system on the planet. In fact, I figured out a long time ago that there wasn't just one Trueborn, but two."

Belial's heart turned cold.

"What... what did you say?"

"Two Trueborn." Ose replied, still not bothering to look at the two of them. "Though they are both frighteningly good at evading my detection. I couldn't uncover their identities, despite my best efforts."

She paused.

"One of them seems to reside either in Russia, Germany, or France. They are a teleportation-type Hero with other potentially unknown abilities. They seem to be an Esper with abilities not dissimilar to mine, though their technological prowess is far beneath mine. This is made up for by their other abilities, many of which I can only hazard guesses regarding."

She continued. "The other one is primarily located here in the United States. I have tried for years to observe him in the field, but he has a supernatural method of evading my detection net. I do know his identity, though."

Lucifer and Belial looked at each other in shock. While they were both just starting to uncover the slightest whiff of a Hero, Ose had known for over a decade but said nothing! Lucifer was the most bothered by this revelation, because... why would her precious little girl not tell her??

"The one you're talking about. Is his name Jason Hiro?" Belial asked, her tone somewhat muted.

"No." Ose replied. "The second Hero I detected... I don't know his real name. But I know his pseudonym. His identity is... Cat Mask. He is an internationally recognized assassin with the ability to accurately snipe at any target with perfect precision. Beyond that, I believe he has more subtle abilities, ones I cannot pinpoint."

Ose finally turned to look at Belial.

"Jason Hiro is the *third* Trueborn. I only learned about him for the first time less than a week ago. I am fully aware that he was taken by the Illuminati, and I've been waiting to make my move on their compound."

"Th-th-*third* Trueborn?!" Belial exclaimed, her skin turning a pale pink. "There's three of them? That's not possible! Not possible at ALL!"

"I thought so too, years ago." Ose said, before pausing for a few moments to look off to the side. "We know Trueborn Heroes only rise once in a generation. What if there was only one Trueborn, and the other two were merely powerful Lowborn? But no, that isn't the case. I've personally verified that all three of them have Heroic Energy Signatures as powerful as each other. What I don't know is who they are, what their exact abilities are, and how much of a threat they pose."

Ose pursed her lips.

"The secret societies have been quietly gathering up Lowborn across the world. I've never seen so many appear all at once. Something changed. I don't know what, how, or why, but I do know it represents an existential threat to demonkind. We've never seen this many Lowborn emerge at once, and certainly not multiple Trueborn. It seems the Nazis were not as unsuccessful as we thought."

Lucifer stared at her daughter. She still felt miffed at not being informed of this incredibly important matter, but she also felt extremely proud. It was obvious Ose had done her due diligence! She was not known as demonkind's secret genius for no reason.

"Sweetie." Lucifer said. "I know you are holding something back. You have a theory about the Trueborn... correct?"

Ose faintly smiled. She closed her eyes and shook her head.

"You always do see through me, mother. That's right. I have a bit of a strange theory, indeed."

Ose opened her eyes.

"I believe that all three of these Heroes are related, likely by blood. I believe they may all be siblings. Specifically... I believe they are all the descendants of Harold Whittaker."

A veil seemingly parted before Belial and Lucifer's eyes. The two of them fell into introspection as they mulled this possibility over.

"Supposedly, Harold died from the injuries he sustained during the war." Belial said. "I heard he didn't live past the 1950's."

"A decade is a great deal of time." Lucifer added. "You know humans. They breed like rabbits. Maybe he and his wife bore a few kids in secret. Maybe he had an affair with another woman, or multiple of them."

Ose tilted her chin up. "The original Heroic Aura belonged to the first Trueborn, the Illuminator, Jepthath. Originally, the aura would have passed down to his descendants, until Archangel Raphael altered how it worked. I believe it's possible the Nazis found a way to reverse this change, returning it to the state of a bloodline ability. This is extremely bad news for us, as it means we will have more Heroes to face as enemies... but the situation may not be entirely bleak."

Belial perked her ears up. "What do you mean?"

Ose detached herself from her computer nexus. Her body sagged a little as she dropped to the floor, then began walking toward her mother and their three guests.

"If the Heroic Aura is as it was, then killing a Trueborn has negligible impact on humanity's long-term prospects. A new one will simply be born elsewhere, grow up, and become a threat within one to two decades."

She stopped an arm's length from the other demons.

"But what if that isn't the case anymore? If the Heroic Aura is no longer a transient entity that jumps from person to person... then that means we have a chance to snuff it out... *once and for all*."

Ose grinned evilly. A cruel and malicious light flickered in her eyes.

"Don't you get it? If we kill all the Trueborn on Earth right now, before they can breed and have more children, we can prevent the rise of all future Heroes. We already thought we did once, but the humans tricked us. Yet their long-term deception hasn't quite paid off! These three Trueborn are vulnerable. We have a shot at killing them right now, before they can start expanding their numbers. If we move quickly, we can finally bring an end to this millennia-long stalemate!"

She paused, Her evil smile disappeared.

"However, calling it a 'stalemate' is also inaccurate. The humans are rapidly evolving their technology. I can keep up with all those changes on my own, but the rest of you cannot. It may not be long before they start inventing weapons and armor that can take down Dukes and Emperors. What then? Even without a Hero, they will crush us!"

Belial nodded. Her expression turned grave.

"We have a narrow window of opportunity." Belial muttered. "We have to strike before the Heroes multiply to even more ludicrous numbers, and before humanity's technology reaches a level that seriously threatens us."

"Precisely." Ose said. "But for now, we need intel. That's why I'll be going with you. You want to infiltrate the Illuminati compound and uncover the Trueborn's identity? So do I."

"I shall go, too." Lucifer said, straightening her posture. "Let us forget our differences for a while. This is bigger than both of us."

Belial looked uneasy, but she had to admit Lucifer was a powerhouse. With her at their side, the infiltration was bound to be a success.

The only problem was, Lucifer loved killing humans. Belial had no idea if 'sneaking' was even an option for the overbearing Emperor.

"Alright..." Belial said slowly. "But this is my mission, handed down by Satan directly. I'm in charge."

Lucifer spread her mouth in a horrifying shark-like approximation of a smile.

"Sure. **You** take the lead." Lucifer said.

Just as the group was about to leave, Ose threw out one last thing.

"I'm going to bring a couple other demons, mother."

Lucifer's smile became a bit warmer and less sadistic as she turned to face her daughter. "Of course, sweetheart. Who have you chosen?"

"Abby, for her ability to influence the minds of humans from a great distance." Ose said. "And also... my brother."

Lucifer's smile evaporated. "Abby is a fine choice, but even that worthless idiot, Gressil? All he does is sit around playing with butterflies all day! There must be a better choice!"

Ose appeared slightly uncomfortable. "Mother..."

"Oh, all right! Bah, if you want to bring him, then do as you please!" Lucifer snarled. "But he'd better not compromise the mission!"

"I'll make sure he doesn't." Ose promised.

Belial scratched her head.

Gressil... Gressil...

Had she heard that demon's name before?

Everyone knew Ose. She was a rare talent among Barons, gifted with technological capabilities that made her utterly unique.

As for Ose's 'brother', Belial didn't remember ever speaking to him. He likely wasn't anyone important. Lucifer's words seemed to correlate with her guess.

Before long, a cute and bubbly demoness joined the group. She rushed over and latched onto Ose's arm while squealing excitedly. "Ooooh, Ose! You called for me specifically?! That's great! I'm so happy!!"

Ose grimaced. "Your abilities will come in handy for this infiltration mission... but that's all. Release my arm. We're not close."

"Of COURSE we're close! We're like besties!" Abby, the Baron of Happy Thoughts declared.

While Abby pestered and latched onto Ose, Belial directed her attention to the other latecomer. He was a thin, gangly, utterly unimpressive looking demon. His face was moody, his hair scraggly. He looked off into the distance, seemingly absorbed in his own thoughts. If ever there was a ranking list of anti-social rejects among demonkind, he would be in the number one position. Belial couldn't believe such a pathetic looking demon existed!

"Gressil!" Lucifer snapped, hissing at him in her usual overbearing manner. "This is Emperor Belial! Introduce yourself!"

Gressil looked at Belial. Despite her attractive appearance, he didn't seem even the slightest bit interested.

"...Hello." Gressil said, after several long seconds.

Then he looked away again.

Despite her immediate revulsion, Belial also felt a different way toward him. That one single word conveyed a level of unimaginable depression. She realized with a start that this 'Gressil' likely lived a sad life, being bossed and bullied by one of the meanest possible 'mothers' who could have ever adopted him.

Naturally, Lucifer was not truly Gressil and Ose's parent. More likely, she had adopted them at some point in the past, as did many older demons. Rumor had it Agares was looking for a protege, though the few he'd found had turned out to be rather inadequate. It was a bit of a surprise that Lucifer hadn't just cut Gressil loose if she hated him so much.

"It's nice to meet you, Gressil." Belial said, smiling as cheerfully as she could manage. But the young demon didn't seem to notice her efforts. He simply continued gazing off into the distance, as if nothing happening now mattered to him.

After adding in these final two members, Belial returned her attention to the task at hand.

"Alright. The sooner we move out, the better." Belial said. "Let's uncover the conspiracy behind all these Trueborn."

Part 632: Ancient Rivalries

January 21st, 2021. 4AM.

Normally, it would take the group of demons over half a day to make their way back north to the Illuminati's base. However, thanks to Belial and Lucifer's contacts, they were able to arrange a direct Warper teleportation array into the woodlands only fifty or so miles from the Illuminati's Haven. Any closer, and the demons risked detection. With so many Emperors gathered together, their demonic auras were sure to cause a spike in the humans' energy scanners.

As they appeared inside a densely wooded forest area, Ose gestured toward a huge knapsack she'd brought along. As a Demon Baron, she had a powerful physical body. Her strength was many times higher than even the strongest human bodybuilder, so carrying a full ton of equipment meant nothing to her, let alone a bag of seemingly random knick-knacks.

"I cannot predict if the Illuminati will know we're coming." Ose warned the others. "It is entirely possible we're walking into a trap. If we're not, then hopefully my precautions will protect us. But first, let's discuss operational roles. Belial?"

Belial nodded. As the leader of this expedition, she would take the full blame if anything went wrong, so it would be up to her to decide how they proceeded.

"This expedition into a human fortress will not be simple. We have clashed with the Illuminati many times. They are well aware of my abilities, and are certain to have taken precautions against me. However, Ose is one of our better-kept secrets. The humans know she exists, and that she is our sole technomancer, but I doubt they are aware of just how adept she is at manipulating their gadgets."

Belial glanced around the group.

"I will be infiltrating the base, while Ose will be assisting me. But all of you can provide additional support in your own way. Lucifer, your third eye can see through any obstruction. Your job is long-range reconnaissance and communications. It will be up to you to keep us appraised on the situation in the base. If need be, use your powers to knock the humans unconscious or trap them in their... nightmares. Try not to set off any alarms, though."

Lucifer snorted. "I'm not *stupid*. I know how to handle myself."

Belial forced a smile. "Of course you aren't. I wouldn't imply otherwise. Murmur, your telekinesis will be best used to create distractions, or to help us fight our way out in the event the humans discover my presence."

Murmur nodded quietly. "Okay."

She almost never had anything to say.

Bael pointed his thumb at himself. "What about me??"

"Same story as Murmur." Belial explained. "After me, you're our strongest combat asset. If things go south, you'll jump in and help me break out."

Bael nodded seriously. "Gotcha. Which way is south again? And what if they go north instead? Do I, uh, keep quiet?"

Belial stared at Bael for five long seconds. Then she looked away, not bothering to answer his thick-headed question.

"Ose. I want you to send out your Astral Body. I'm sure to run into devices I can't open, passwords that need cracking, other human stuff. Can you get past them without being there in person?"

Ose sneered. "That will be the *easiest* part. Nobody can detect me in my Astral Form if I don't want them doing so."

Belial nodded. She turned to the last demon.

"Abby, I'm not familiar with your powers, but you're a Baron, so they must be good. Care to elaborate?"

Abby, who was standing as close to Ose as she possibly could without touching her, smiled giddily.

"Of course! I have a bunch of powers, but mainly I specialize in influencing minds and emotions. I can make people see things that aren't there, make them start thinking about memories from their pasts, fantasize about *particularly* hot and heavy-"

"I see." Belial interrupted, before Abby could say anything weird. "That's good. Your power should synergize with mine. I assume your abilities work at long range?"

Abby nodded. "Against other demons, I have to get up close and personal, but human minds are suuuuper weak and easy to influence."

"Then while I'm breaking in, you'll focus on distracting the humans to give me more leeway." Belial concluded. "Monitor them to see if anyone is holding any suspicious thoughts, and if they are, draw their attention elsewhere."

"Okay! Sounds easy enough." Abby chirped cutely.

"Good." Belial said with a nod. "Then it's settled. We should reach their Haven within thirty minutes if we run at just below top speed-"

"Wait." Ose interrupted. "You're forgetting someone."

Belial blinked. She followed Ose's hands as the demoness gestured to her side.

"Oh. Right. Gressil." Belial said, raising an eyebrow. "Ahh... and your abilities are...?"

Gressil didn't seem to hear her. He looked off to the side, as if lost in his own little world.

"Gressil?" Belial asked. "Gressil??"

Finally, the moody young demon blinked. He turned his head slightly to look at her. "Huh?"

"Your powers." Belial repeated. "What are they?"

"He summons *butterflies*." Lucifer sneered. "Stupid, worthless butterflies. I told you we were better off not bringing-"

"Mother!" Ose snapped, irritation on her face. Seeing that her words shut Belial up, Ose forced herself to regain her center of calm. "Gressil is... an illusionist. He can conjure illusions. It's not *just* butterflies. He's sort of like a mini-Raphael."

Lucifer rolled all three of her eyes. "Yes, yes, he can summon bats and birds too. Truly *terrifying*."

Gressil lowered his eyes. Lucifer's words seemed to hurt his feelings. He didn't say anything in response.

Belial frowned. Lucifer's constant denigration of her 'son' made Belial feel deeply uncomfortable. It was unnecessary and detrimental to the mission. If he was coming, then Belial couldn't allow Gressil to act like or think of himself as a useless burden. He might act too slowly in a moment of crisis and cause a catastrophe.

"Gressil..." Belial said softly. "You're an illusionist?"

Gressil lifted his eyes for a moment to look at Belial, then he lowered them again.

"...Yes." Gressil said, his reply barely audible.

Belial shot Lucifer a warning glare before returning her gaze to the young demon. "I happen to think illusions can be extremely powerful under the right circumstances. Can you perhaps cloak our bodies to make us harder to detect as we approach?"

Gressil looked at Belial once more. He stared at her for a good few seconds, then slowly nodded.

"...sible..." Gressil mumbled.

"What was that?" Belial asked, smiling a little to try and lift his spirits.

"I can... become... invisible..." Gressil mumbled. "Hide myself. Maybe hide... everyone here. Haven't tried before..."

"Whoa!" Belial exclaimed. "If you really can, that would be a huge help. Will you be able to maintain the illusion while we're on the move, even while racing through the forest?"

Gressil smiled, though only by the tiniest bit. "...Maybe. I can... try."

His slow way of speaking told Belial what she needed to know. Every demon had the ability to accomplish great things. It was clear that his confidence had been shattered long ago. He had lost faith in himself, and had lost his spark of curiosity. It was no wonder, with Lucifer constantly mocking and insulting him.

Belial's smile turned somewhat somber. She felt the young demon was a tragic figure. The way he looked at her, like a dog that had received the first treat of its entire life, made her want to envelop him in a motherly hug and tell him everything would be all right.

But obviously, this was neither the time nor the place. The clock was ticking, and dawn's first light would soon arrive. It was more important to get Gressil in gear and ready for action while getting his mother to shut up about him for a few hours than it was to worry about his self-esteem.

After learning a bit more about him and investigating his powers, Belial pulled Lucifer away and took care to lower her voice. The other demons all had sharp hearing, and Belial wanted this conversation to be at least a *little* bit private.

"I don't want to hear another word from you. Not one word, about Gressil, for the rest of this mission." Belial hissed. "Got it? I don't care if you think he's worthless, or stupid, or whatever else. Keep your snide comments to yourself."

"Don't tell me what to do." Lucifer bit back, puffing her chest out. She poked her finger in Belial's face in a provoking manner. "He's *my* son, and I'll tell him whatever I want. The stupid idiot needs some tough love."

"Tough love? There's no love in anything you say!" Belial whispered. "Just shut your mouth for a few hours. It won't kill you, and it might allow all of us to also avoid getting killed."

Lucifer frowned. "You're taking these humans way too seriously."

"No. *You're* not taking them seriously *enough*." Belial retorted. "Did you not hear a single devil-damned thing your daughter said? There are not one, not two, but *three* bloody Trueborn out there! Unknown powers, unknown appearances. We could be walking right into an ambush! I will not allow you to put all our lives in danger. If you can't shut your trap, then you're off the mission."

Lucifer sneered. "If you cut me out, Ose, Gressil, and Abby stay with me."

Belial cocked her head. "Are you telling me I should involve Satan in this little spat? Do you think he'd let you off easy, knowing the stakes?"

Lucifer's haughty grin evaporated. She glowered at Belial, seething under the surface.

Lucifer had few compunctions. She was an insanely powerful and versatile demoness. Against even the mightiest Archangel, she could come out on top, or at least escape with her life.

But Satan was the one entity she could not afford to piss off. She had gone against him only a few times in the past, and she nearly died every time. The only reason she still drew breath was because Satan had let her live. Unfortunately, he had forced her to sign one of his contracts. It wasn't a slave contract, like what he made lesser demons sign, but it allowed him to always know her location, no matter where she hid.

If she enraged Satan, he would come for her. She would not come out the victor.

The Emperor of Providence bristled, but could not offer a retort. She glared daggers at Belial, but ultimately relented. She wouldn't mind beating the shit out of her rival, but if she went too far, she would not escape Satan's wrath. Such was the control he held over all the other Hells. When shit hit the fan, they always fell in line.

"Fine." Lucifer practically spat. "I'll... keep my comments to myself. Happy?"

Belial forced herself to smile in the most sickeningly cutesy way she could. "Oh, thank you, *Lucy*. You're always so understanding! *Teehee*!"

Belial playfully scampered away, leaving Lucifer's eyes twitching and her teeth gnashing.

"Don't... call me... Lucy... you *bitch*..."

Minutes later, the demons regrouped. Gressil summoned his illusions to cover all of them with light-bending distortions, and they became nearly invisible. Even radar would have a hard time spotting them. Then, Ose reached into her bulky knapsack and pulled out wristbands that she tossed to all the demons.

"I reverse-engineered the human's scanners. These are Energy Inhibitors. They will greatly weaken demonic energy signatures, especially for higher ranking demons. However, they will also inhibit your powers a bit. If we end up fighting, then rip them off. Crush them into powder if possible so the humans can't salvage anything. They'll allow us to sneak onto the outside of the base without being detected."

Belial nodded. She wrapped the band around her wrist and instantly felt her internal energy being suppressed through some unknown mechanism. At the same time, she nearly lost track of the other demons, since she stopped being able to sense their presences.

"What a marvelous invention. Not bad for technology based on human stuff." Belial casually commented.

Ose glared at her. "It isn't human-based. *I* made it from scratch."

"Oh. Sorry, I didn't know." Belial apologized.

Ose didn't seem very accepting of the apology. Like mother, like daughter.

Without further ado, the demons all started running toward the Illuminati compound at full speed. Instead of fanning out, they stuck together, their footsteps somewhat loud due to the speed of their travel and the strength in their legs. Bael was easily the loudest. Each impact of his foot against the ground sounded like a boulder falling off a cliff. The group had to stick together so Gressil could keep everyone hidden, but Bael's damned stomping would likely give them away without the humans needing to physically spot them!

Belial directed a quick appreciative glance at Gressil. It turned out he was a Baron, like his sister, but also a complete unknown. Belial hadn't heard of him before, so she had no idea how he obtained the souls needed to become one. Did Lucifer empower him in spite of her irrational hatred?

Belial wasn't sure. She pushed those thoughts aside, and once they drew within three miles of the base, she forced everyone to slow down. They continued to run, but much more quietly and cautiously. As high ranking demons, their stamina levels were far beyond any human. They could run for an entire day without feeling winded. Naturally, long and constant exertion would eventually exhaust them and force a sleep, but in general demons didn't really *need* sleep, they simply rested once a week or so to keep themselves in prime physical condition.

After reaching the one-mile mark, they slowed to a steady walk. The demons began to creep forward, using their formidable senses to sweep the area and locate human sentries, technology-based scanning devices, cameras, and other such things.

Belial truly felt relieved that she had brought so many other demons along. Ose in particular was a huge help! Time and time again, Ose surreptitiously hacked a device before Belial and the others even knew it would be a problem. She set cameras to loop their video feeds, fed scanners with false information, and otherwise subverted every system they passed. Belial even started to feel sorry for the humans. They had no idea how much danger they were in and still thought themselves safe behind their walls.

At the same time, Abby and Lucifer played a key role during the approach. Abby was able to sense emotions, and since it was mainly Sentients who possessed them, she could tell when humans were near and distract them with idle thoughts, allowing the demons to sneak right past.

But even if Abby weren't present, Lucifer's third eye was even more terrifying. She could see through the jungle as easily as if it were a barren desert. Trees, boulders, fauna and flora, none of these things were an impediment to her third eye. Even with Ose's suppression bracelet weakening her abilities, it didn't affect her physical body or her third eye in the slightest. In terms of physicality, she was still at full strength.

Bael, on the other hand, contributed nothing during this phase of the mission. As they approached the hundred-meter mark and Lucifer announced that the Haven's walls were near, Bael quietly yawned.

"Man. I hope there's some action." Bael grumbled under his breath. "Sneaking around with a bunch of broads is so boring. Ain't that right, kid?"

He sent a huge grin in Gressil's direction, but the young male only gave him a raised eyebrow in confusion before refocusing on keeping the others invisible.

Bael's grin faltered, then he looked away. "...Never mind."

As Bael continued to mutter to himself, Belial finally brought the group to a standstill. She turned back to look at Lucifer, Murmur, Bael, Ose, Abby, and Gressil, all of whom met her eyes, one by one.

"This next part... is my burden to bear." Belial whispered. "We have about 45 minutes until dawn arrives. 6AM is my exit timer. Ose, keep close to me. Continue subverting the human's technology. Lucifer, Abby, you know what to do. The rest of you, stay on standby. I'm leaving now."

Bael yawned again. "Oh, alright, toots. See ya later. Bring me some snacks on the way back. Chips would be nice."

Belial rolled her eyes. She stepped forward, changed her appearance, and materialized inside the uniform of an Illuminati outer guard.

At the same time, Ose sat down, closed her eyes, and projected an astral figure of herself into reality. Unlike her future self, this projection was much fainter, which helped with making it even harder to detect, but it also weakened the effectiveness she had in manipulating the real world with her powers. Her ability to astrally project over long distances was also much weaker, but since she had yet to become an Emperor, she had no idea this weakness could be alleviated.

Not hesitating for even a moment longer, Belial began to quickly sneak forward, slithering through the trees like a snake in the tall grass. It didn't take her long before she sensed a human up ahead. It turned out to be someone wearing full tactical gear, covering their face and body from head to toe.

"Who's there?" The man asked, snapping to face the unexpected visitor. He took aim with his AR-15, narrowing his eyes when he caught a glimpse of someone wearing Illuiminati-issued tactical gear approaching from a strange direction. By the time he noticed the other person didn't have any guns or other tactical gear attached to their person, it was too late for him.

Belial pounced. She dove onto the man faster than he thought possible. His pupils shrunk to pinpricks as she ripped the gun from his hands.

"Help-!" The man started to shout, but a light slap from Belial knocked him unconscious. She made quick work of his uniform, stealing various pieces of equipment, his rifle, and his sidearm. She took off his helmet and touched his face, then her body changed form as she perfectly mimicked his appearance.

The man woke up a minute later, his head throbbing. He opened his eyes to see his own face staring at him, but the odd thing was, the other 'him' had glowing pink eyes.

Strange. Why did his other self appear so… *attractive*?"

"Hey, big boy." The man's other self said, his voice hauntingly seductive. "Why don't you tell me *all* about yourself. What's your name, stud?"

The man's speech slurred. "Private… Jameson… Little… Rank 3."

"How long have you been on this base, Jamey-boy?" Belial asked.

"Four years… two months…" Jameson mumbled.

Belial spent a couple precious minutes extracting valuable intel from the man. She identified key weaknesses in the Illuminati's defenses, then caressed Jameson's cheek.

"You're such a good boy." She cooed. "Why don't you sleep for a while, sweetie? A few hours will do. You're *real* tired."

Jameson blinked his eyes slowly. "Yeah… I am… tired……."

He closed his eyes one last time, then drifted off to a deep sleep.

Ose, watching from behind Belial, grimaced. She felt sickened and repulsed by the ease in which Belial seduced the disgusting human. Ose herself hated humans. She studied them, learned about them, and became an expert on their ways, but only out of hatred. Ever since the ancient times when King Arthur nearly had many members of her brood-family slaughtered, she had hated humans. Arthur's subordinates had killed two of her brothers, leaving only Gressil behind.

Ose didn't know if she still loved Gressil. She knew he was at least somewhat important to her. She also hated that her adoptive mother always insulted him.

Gressil was different before the humans captured him. He was actually the strongest of her three brothers, and the first to ascend to Baron. But after that horrible day in Arthur's

dungeons, he mentally broke. He lost too much, too abruptly. He shut down mentally, and the formidable Baron who Lucifer hastily adopted ended up a worthless investment in her eyes.

Ose knew why her mother hated Gressil. She would have thrown him away like garbage a long time ago, but she valued Ose highly and knew if she did truly dispose of Gressil, Ose would hate her. Even so, she simply couldn't hide her contempt for 'weaklings.' And Ose enabled her mother's actions because she liked being praised by such a powerful demoness. It helped that in her time of greatest need, Ose had been rescued by Lucifer, and therefore she bonded with her easily.

Ose's astral body sighed softly.

She didn't like the current status quo with her adoptive mother and blood-brother, but she felt too weak and powerless to change anything, and ultimately Ose herself benefited from the arrangement. As important as her older brother was, her revenge on the humans was even more so.

The humans had to suffer. They *had* to pay for what they had done to her demon family, and so many others.

Belial looked behind herself. She could only just barely sense Ose's presence, but she couldn't see the Baron's astral body at all.

"Let's go." Belial whispered.

[Sure.] Ose said, her voice transmitting inside Belial's mind.

As much as Ose loathed Belial's disgusting human-seducing ways, ultimately she would tolerate them. All means and measures were acceptable in Ose's grand goal of someday exterminating humanity.

While Belial infiltrated, Ose assisted... and she pondered a great many things.

Perhaps the arrival of these three Trueborn wasn't such a bad thing.

Maybe they could be *used*. They could form a Threat.

As the humans always said, schemers should never let crises go to waste...

Part 633: Haven Infiltration

January 21st, 2021. 5AM.

Private Jameson Little walked up to the entrance of the Illuminati Haven. He held his stomach as he approached, and paused when the entry guard held up his palm.

"Jamie? Your shift isn't over for another two hours."

The gate guard's face was cloaked, so determining his identity shouldn't have been easy, but Private Little still forced a pained smile and responded normally.

"Ahh, Marco, I... this is a little embarrassing... can I swap? I need to... you know?"

"Need to... *what*?" Marco, the entry guard, asked. He narrowed his eyes under his mask, and the other guard on the opposite side casually aimed his weapon at the Private.

"I... I gotta take a shit!" Jameson hissed, lowering his head out of embarrassment. "I'm practically growing a tail here, man!"

"Jesus, seriously? You're supposed to use the bathroom *before* you- goddammit, Jamie. Protocols are protocols for a reason. Fucking hell..."

Marco cursed under his breath, then touched the side of his head and spoke into his mic. Jamie stood in place, shifting uncomfortably, trying not to be too obvious about doing his potty-dance while waiting for the gate to open. Eventually, it did, and another soldier stepped out, looked at him, and nodded.

"Get in there. Go before you shit yourself and make us look like idiots." Marco growled.

"Th-thanks! Sorry, Marco, sorry..." Jameson said, racing inside.

After entering, Jameson trotted over to the shared men's bathroom inside the Haven's walls. Naturally, he wouldn't have to go down into the complex for such a minor thing, as they already had installed such facilities in the upper area. Jameson walked inside, where he found another man pissing into a urinal. He ignored that man, and quickly stepped into a stall, shut the door, and started unzipping and removing his pants.

"You're back early." The guy pissing said.

"Had to take a shit." Jameson said, his voice tinged with panic. At that moment, an explosive noise erupted inside the toilet, and he moaned audibly.

"God damn, what the fuck did you eat?" The urinating man asked. "Nah, I'm out. I'm out!"

He hurriedly zipped up his pants and raced outside without bothering to wash his hands. He did not want to be there for when the stench hit.

After about thirty seconds, the stall opened, and Jameson emerged.

Ose levitated nearby. She frowned. [Did you actually...?]

"No." 'Jameson' answered. "I morphed my lower body into an organ capable of replicating the sound. I doubt you want the details."

Ose's mouth curled up into a deep expression of revulsion. Since Belial couldn't see her, she had no idea how much she had just disgusted the prim and proper Baron.

"No. I don't." Ose said, wondering if it was possible for her astral body to projectile vomit. She hadn't ever contemplated such a thing before, but she truly found Belial to be a disgusting and degenerate demoness. Everything about her repulsed Ose on a fundamental level.

Ose was neat. Tidy. She looked upon herself as an untainted woman, clean of impurities. She had never known a man, and had never met one who even remotely interested her. Frankly, she didn't think such a man existed. That didn't mean she was interested in women or any of the other options either. In many ways, she saw herself as asexual, perhaps even sex-repulsed. Therefore, Belial's inherently sexual nature made her feel like Ose's polar opposite. The two were fundamentally incompatible on philosophical levels, and the more time Ose spent with Belial, the more she hated her.

It didn't help that her mother hated Belial too, albeit for entirely different reasons.

Ose eventually swallowed her disgust and refocused her mind.

[The first part of the plan is complete. You're inside the Haven. What do you intend to do now?]

Since Belial was both leading the operation and the primary infiltrator, all changes in plan were at her discretion. She took the biggest risk by physically entering the humans' base, so she had to prioritize her safety.

"Investigate the nearby guards. Are there any males carrying things you can use to identify them? Badges and so on? Can you manipulate the cameras so I can slip out of here?"

Ose smirked. [I can do a lot more than that. The other guards will be expecting your return, though. You're only supposed to use the bathroom, then travel back outside.]

"Have Abby deceive the guards. Make them think I left." Belial ordered. "Also, cover me while I leave here. Shut off the nearby cameras for a few moments."

Ose nodded, a motion Belial didn't see. Then, she reached out with her electrical powers and tapped into the camera feeds. In an instant, she altered all of them to loop the video feeds while also opening her physical body's mouth to communicate with Abby.

Ose's body sat in a lotus pose back with the other demons, her legs folded, her eyes shut, and her head bowed. When she spoke, Abby nearly jumped out of her skin; not helped by the fact she was hovering creepily close to Ose and nearly drooling on her leg while admiring Ose's perfect beauty from an unnervingly close distance.

"Abby. Belial wants you to use your powers on the guards." Ose said, before explaining the rest a few moments later.

Abby quickly recovered from her fright. "Okay! I can't exactly do what she wants, but I can confuse all of them a little bit. I'll just make them think the guard was given a temporary leave and allowed to return to his dorm."

"That will work." Ose responded.

Ose informed Belial of the new plan, and the Emperor of Passion nodded. She morphed her body again, this time turning into a long, slender, almost vine-like fleshy object. Belial clung to the wall, then pressed a window facing behind the bathrooms slightly open before slithering through the gap like a snake would. After leaving, she returned to the appearance of an Illuminati guard decked in full armor, then closed the window behind her. From here, the next part was a bit easier.

Belial simply strolled toward the inner base, utterly casual in her movements. She looked around with the same level of alertness expected of any average interior guard, swiveling her head from side to side, seemingly looking for threats. In actuality, she was assessing escape routes, ambush locations, and other potential pain points that might affect the later stages of the mission.

By acting like she belonged, Belial exploited humanity's innate lack of caution toward uniformed officers. She walked right past mechanics, civilian personnel, and other uniformed guards, giving a casual nod to the latter to assure them that she was, in fact, one of them.

As she approached the doors leading into the inner base, Belial's mind worked to plot several potential courses of action. Ose dutifully bypassed the keypad and gave Belial the code through telepathy, so the Emperor of Passion was able to casually type it in as if it were something she had done a thousand times.

She passed by a camera without even looking at it, assuming correctly that Ose was using her lightning-fast mind to subvert them well before Belial entered their view. However, Belial ran into a snag as she approached the end of a long hallway leading to an elevator heading down into the base. Beside the elevator, an armed guard stood. She was a woman, so Belial's succubi powers wouldn't work on her.

Ose hovered behind Belial. She frowned. How would Belial deal with this?

Then, Ose's gaze fell on the Emperor of Passion. When it did, her astral eyes metaphorically popped out of their sockets.

On Belial's back, unseen by the guard she was casually approaching, words materialized on a patch of bare skin that revealed itself when the back of her shirt opened up. Like tattoos instantly drawn by the world's fastest tattoo artist, the words came and went, but not too rapidly for Ose to keep up.

OSE

DISTRACT

GUARD

OR

UNCOVER

HER

IDENTITY

AND

GIVE

ME

HER

NAME.

* * *

Ose blinked. In an instant, she understood Belial's intent.

She snapped her eyes onto a nearby wall-panel, then dove her mind inside. She located the entire base's personnel list, narrowed it down to specific roles, narrowed those roles down by gender, then visually scanned the faces of every registered guard until she found the young woman's name.

[Her name is Natalie Summers. Age twenty. She was originally a guard assigned to protect the Trueborn, but after a recent failure on her end, she was assigned to internal guard duty as punishment.]

The words on Belial's back shimmered once again. She was almost within conversational range of Natalie, and it would start to look suspicious if she didn't greet her fellow officer.

IS

NATALIE

CLOSE

WITH

JAMESON?

Ose frowned. This was a difficult question to answer. The personnel records couldn't possibly give her such information, and scanning other databases would take way too long!

[I.. I don't...] Ose said, her voice tinged with alarm. She didn't know how to respond. There was no time!

The rear of Belial's upper body armor abruptly closed up, and she didn't bother communicating with Ose again. She had already assumed obtaining such information wouldn't be possible, but it was worth a shot.

Instead, she kept her attitude casual. Belial walked up to Natalie, her face obscured by her helmet and goggles. She looked directly at Natalie, then nodded.

Natalie looked back at her. She smiled.

"Nothing to say?" Natalie asked.

Belial's mind jolted into action. She instantly intuited several contextual clues based on the young woman's body language and the hidden meaning behind those three words.

"Hey, babe." Belial said dryly, her tone one of exhaustion. "They let me off early today. I caught something, not sure what."

"You did?" Natalie asked, her forehead knitting in concern. "You were fine earlier, Jamie."

Belial paused only a few feet away from Natalie. She reached up and pulled her helmet back, then sighed heavily as she revealed her face.

"Oh, oh my god!" Natalie exclaimed. "Jamie, you need to see the doctor ASAP!"

Ose, hovering behind Belial, frowned. She quickly flitted forward to look at Belial's face, and her expression warped to disgust and then to horror. Belial's face was covered in dozens of red zit-like dots, making her look as if she had caught leprosy!

"Huh? You're kidding." Belial muttered. "It can't be that bad..."

"You look like you're at death's door!" Natalie exclaimed. "I'll call for backup."

"Nah, nah. I'll go, I'll go. Stay here." Belial said, her heart skipping a beat. Calling for backup was the exact opposite thing she wanted. "I'll go to the doctor if you think it's that bad."

"...Right away?" Natalie asked, her tone turning to concern.

Belial nodded. "As soon as I make it down there. Promise, alright?"

Belial smiled weirdly, then leered toward Natalie. "Kiss?"

"Eww, no!" Natalie exclaimed, recoiling from her plague-stricken boyfriend in horror. "Jamie, this is no time for jokes. Get down there right now!"

"Alright, alright. I'm going." Belial said.

She entered the elevator and turned around, observing Natalie's concerned expression as the doors closed, separating the two of them.

With that, Belial keyed the elevator to drop to the lower floors, then her helmet shifted on its own to cover her face once more. Naturally, her false leprosy vanished without a trace.

As the elevator dropped, Ose looked at her curiously.

[How did you know Jamie was Natalie's lover?] Ose asked.

"I have a lot of experience living as and communicating with both genders." Belial said quietly. "I could tell her relationship with Jamie wasn't ordinary. I can also tell it's a secret one. Private Jameson Little is thirty-two years old. Natalie is only twenty. They seem to have known each other for a few years... possibly more than two. I'm guessing their superiors don't know about their relationship."

Ose frowned. Humans lived far shorter lives than demons, so it was often hard for demons to comprehend age-based human issues, but she was well aware of at least a few human sexual dynamics.

[You think, before she was considered of legal age...?]

"It's hard to say." Belial replied, shrugging. "But anything is possible. Trust me, modern sensibilities about age are far better for human women than the ancient ones. The kings and nobles of the past used to hoard harems of little girls for their own pleasure and amusement."

She paused.

"Some still do. They simply don't display it openly."

Ose scowled. [Disgusting humans.]

"Sometimes, their species can be truly vile." Belial agreed.

The elevator door opened, and Belial found herself on the sixth floor of the underground complex. Thanks to Ose's intelligence gathering capabilities, they had both determined the Hero Testing Center was on this level, and it was likely to hold some key information regarding Jason Hiro, the newest Trueborn.

As Belial exited the elevator, her ears perked up. With her enhanced hearing, she overheard a pair of human scientists speaking in a break room somewhere off to the left, and she slightly enlarged her ear canal to amplify their distant conversation.

"-thinks it's a mistake. I tend to agree." A male voice muttered. "We should destroy these files. They provide too much information."

"It is an inspiring Heroic name though." A female voice replied, her voice also low. "It makes him sound like a prophet."

"That's because he is. Can you even imagine how powerful he'll become?" The male asked. "I've never heard of such an exotic ability as 'dream eating.' He's already uncovered all this top-secret information about the demons... who knows what he'll find in a few more years. Maybe we can even start planning some sort of a strike operation... hit them all at once, take their leaders out. Those idiot demons still think they're safe, but we already know where a few of their hideouts are."

Belial's expression shifted. Whatever these humans were talking about, it was highly sensitive and deeply relevant to her mission.

She glanced up at Ose, then tilted her head to the side, gesturing toward those distant voices.

[On it.] Ose replied, before her presence drifted away.

While Ose moved toward those humans, Belial navigated toward the inner laboratory. She paused to press her palm against its outer wall, then opened her mouth to emit an instantaneous, subsonic whistle. Like a bat out of hell, she mapped out the interior of the room on the other side of the wall without alerting anyone inside.

Five humans. Three scientists, a woman in a wheelchair... hm? There seems to be a lightly dressed young man inside. An experimental subject?

Belial's heart turned cold. She continued to press her palm against the wall and focused carefully. Despite the humans' best attempts to soundproof the interior chamber, she was able to parse through vibrations on the other side some of the words being spoken.

"...results...positive...good...work...Jason...satisfactory..."

Belial's eyes widened.

Jason? Was that the name she just heard? Could the Trueborn himself be inside? If it really was him, she had a chance to eliminate his threat right here and now!

But...

Belial frowned.

She wasn't a murderer. In fact, she had never killed anyone in her life. Maybe she could mutilate the Hero. Maim him, sever a few limbs... but what if he had healing powers? What if one of the other Trueborn did? Or what if the humans used their technology to heal him?

This was too good of an opportunity to pass up. If she killed him, it would immediately advance demonkind's interests. Breaking out of the facility would be difficult, but possible. She had backup waiting outside.

However. She simply... *couldn't* bring herself to do it. The Hero was only eighteen years old. Barely an adult, by modern human sensibilities.

Could she murder a child in cold blood?

Belial bit her lip. She wasn't sure what to do.

Suddenly, inside the chamber, there were the sounds of multiple footsteps moving in sync. The door around the corner opened up, and a voice called out. "I told you she was here!"

What? Belial thought, her heart skipping a beat. *They detected me? Impossible! How, so fast?!*

A young man wearing only a pair of blue jeans and sneakers rounded the corner while holding a bo staff. The shirtless youth grinned at Belial knowingly, as if she had completely forgotten to disguise herself.

"They didn't believe me, but I knew you'd come! My predictions always come right! Hahahaha!!!"

The young man pointed his staff at Belial and grinned, a feral look in his eyes.

"Belial, the Emperor of Passion! You really thought you could escape the eyes of I, the legendary Archseer?! I hope you're ready to give me a good fight, you dumb demon bitch!"

Belial's heart jumped. He knew! He really knew it was her! How the hell did he discover her?!

The young man charged at Belial, revealing his nature as a battle-maniac. He laughed wildly and snapped the bo staff at her head while the scientists and Claire Rothschild appeared behind him, looking at his back with fear.

"Jason, no!" Claire shouted. "She's too powerful!"

The young and foolish Hero didn't seem to hear Claire's words. He continued to madly grin, making Belial feel as if Bael were dumbly charging at her. Except she could tell by

Jason's pathetic physique he was badly lacking in strength. If they came to blows, he would definitely lose!

But when the alarms activated inside the Haven, Belial realized she didn't have time to battle this Trueborn. Backup would arrive shortly, and if she were pinned between a Hero and heavily armed Illuminati guardsman, she might suffer a terrible defeat. She might end up captured... or worse!

Belial made a snap judgment. She turned tail and ran.

She bolted back down the hallway, grimacing as she heard Jason's shoes clomping loudly down the corridor behind her.

"Wow! I didn't know you were a coward, too!" Jason proclaimed. He reached into his pants pocket and pulled out a transmitter of some kind, then yelled into it. "This is the Archseer! Demons have surrounded the Haven! Lock down Level Six and prepare for battle! Demon Emperors Belial, Murmur, and Lucifer are on-site, as well as Duke Bael, Barons Abby, and... the primary targets! Ose and Gressil!!"

Belial continued to run. Her pupils shrunk to pinpricks.

The infiltration had been going way too easily! It turned out the Hero not only somehow knew she was there, but he had identified every member of her force.

"Ose!" Belial called out, unsure where her invisible comrade had floated off to. "Retreat!!"

A heavy door slid shut from the ceiling to the floor up ahead. Belial roared with fury and pounded it with her fist, smashing it away and sending it flying down the corridor. It embedded into the far wall, and another door slammed shut in her path.

She broke through that one too!

"Keep slowing her down! Shut off the elevators!" Jason shouted. "I've almost caught up! This stupid bitch has nowhere left to run!"

Belial's face contorted into an expression of rage.

She hated losing, and she hated being played for a fool. She assumed the humans had been planning a trap, but she had no idea the Archseer's abilities could allow him to predict the composition of the infiltration team with such frightening accuracy.

Heroic powers were such BULLSHIT!

Part 634: Annoying Archseer

Recommended Listening

January 21st, 2021. 5AM.

Belial raced toward the elevator, the Archseer hot on her trail. With less than twenty paces separating them, the only way the young Hero could catch up to her was when she was momentarily slowed by trapdoors slamming shut in front of her, but she still blew through them as if they were made of Styrofoam.

Belial tore toward the elevators, stabbed her hands out, and shoved her fingers into the gap between the doors. She ripped the elevator open with contemptuous ease, retracted her arms to yank herself forward, and slammed against the elevator car's wall. Hardly had her body impacted it before she smashed her feet against the floor, leaped upward, and pounded through the ceiling. Her impact broke the chain attaching the elevator to the shaft, causing the elevator car to plummet downward into the depths of the Haven's bottom levels. It struck the shaft's bottom with a distant *boom*, but Belial ignored it.

"Shit! The elevator! You idiots, she's getting away! Stop her!" Jason shouted. He arrived at the entrance to the elevator and shook his fist up at Belial as she rapidly climbed the walls, pouncing from side to side while scaling the shaft far faster than the elevator would have taken her to the top. "Face me if you dare, you cowardly demon!"

Belial didn't bother responding. She couldn't believe what a loudmouthed idiot this newest Trueborn was. All that yelling, declarations about how amazing he was, and constantly shouting out his heroic moniker... wasn't he afraid he'd die from embarrassment? Belial certainly felt a painful level of secondhand cringe radiating off him. It had been ages since Belial could recall a more pathetic hero than this Jason fellow. If they came to blows, didn't he realize she'd kill him with a single slap??

Whatever. Belial thought, as she raced past the fifth, fourth, and third floors. *He doesn't matter now! I need to escape and rendezvous with the others. Then we need to assess how the new Trueborn's powers work. He's weak now, but that might not be the case in the future!*

Belial's demonic senses picked up Jason's Heroic energy beneath her. He slowly moved toward what she assumed was a stairwell and started moving upward, but at the snail's pace he was ascending, she'd be long gone before he made it to the top level.

Seconds later, Belial reached the top of the elevator shaft. She punched through the elevator door, then spotted a group of Illuminati soldiers aiming rifles at her from the end of the corridor.

Blat-blat-blat!

Bullets flew at her before she could react. Belial grimaced as some of the bullets bit into her toughened Emperor skin and glanced off, but a few others found purchase and sunk into her flesh, drawing blood in their wake.

"Rrrgh!" Belial grunted, before narrowing her eyes, slimming down her body, and turning sideways to present the humans with an impossibly slender profile. Just like that, all the bullets started missing as the humans lost the target they were shooting at. Belial's body became so rail-thin that the humans might as well be shooting at a quarter-inch fence post!

The humans continued firing, but Belial shimmied toward them, bending her body left and right to make herself even harder to hit. The soldiers maintained discipline, but all of them flinched when Belial snapped her freakishly skinny fist out, punched their commander's chest, and sent him slamming backward into the wall behind him. Seconds later, all the men and women laid on the ground, coughing and crying as their injured bodies lay humbled in Belial's shadow.

Belial re-inflated herself back to normal size, then healed her injuries before racing forward. She broke out of the entryway and arrived at the underground Haven's exit, right out in the open, where an unknown but assuredly high number of snipers would surely be waiting for her. Unfortunately for the humans, the other demons had not remained idle. Lucifer stood on all fours in their midst, grinning like a feral animal with her shark-like maw. She swiveled her head from side to side. Her third eye fired mighty concussive blasts that slammed into walls and detonated with the force of missiles, blasting humans apart and spraying their entrails all over the place.

Bael leaped into the fray, grinning with a childlike expression of joy. "Finally! I was gonna die of boredom if I had ta' wait any longer! C'mon humans, gimme a good fight!!"

Murmur levitated in the sky. Using her telekinesis, she was a practiced flier who was equally adept at ground and sky combat. She pointed her finger at the humans and made minimal movements while throwing them around and sending them flying.

"Poke. Poke." Murmur said quietly. Nobody heard the words muttered under her breath.

Abby worked hard to distract the humans. She conjured illusions in their minds, making them think even more demons had arrived and an army was on the way. Some of the weaker-willed soldiers mentally broke. They ran away screaming in terror, while others started blindly firing at anything Abby directed their attention toward, which unfortunately included their fellow humans.

Belial didn't spot Gressil and Ose, but that was to be expected. They were only Barons, but Ose might not have returned to her body yet, and Gressil was clearly weak in the ways of battle.

Belial paused for half a second. She frowned.

Why did the Hero say that Ose and Gressil were the primary targets?

She didn't have time to answer that question. Lucifer suddenly screamed as a bullet fired from one of the sniper towers struck her head, just at the edge of her third eye, and blinded her with pain. She stumbled away, clutching her forehead as she tried to find the one who shot her.

"You!!" Lucifer screeched.

Belial looked where Lucifer's gaze was directed. She was astonished to see a previously cloaked Heroic energy signature emerge. A man wearing a Japanese nekomimi mask stood atop the tower, his sniper rifle aimed at Lucifer.

BLAM!

The man's sniper rifle was huge, seemingly unwieldy, but he held it with practiced ease. A single shot rang out, and a bullet flew into Lucifer's open mouth, jamming in the back of her throat and causing her to stagger backward, gagging painfully as the bullet somehow perfectly slid down and lodged in the narrowest crevice within her trachea. Lucifer's eyes bulged. She grabbed at her throat and wheezed, stumbling about in a daze as waves of pain grew ever more intense.

Belial didn't need time to contemplate the situation. She had fought countless battles across her life. She snapped her arm out and grabbed onto a pipe attached to the wall. She tore it off and casually sharpened it by turning her thumb into a knife and swiping diagonally across its shaft. In a single second, she procured a makeshift javelin, and then proceeded to hurl it at the Hero with every ounce of demonic power she could muster.

Cat Mask was, without a doubt, a far bigger threat than the still-green young Hero down below. Jason Hiro was no trouble at all compared to the danger demonstrated by his older peer. Cat Mask's pinpoint accuracy showed he could threaten the Emperors, at least injuring them enough to cause some misery.

Belial could not treat him with the same kid gloves she had his younger comrade!

The javelin raced at Cat Mask. With his attention on Lucifer, there was no way he could react in time.

But he did.

Cat Mask never took his eyes off the Emperor of Providence. Yet, even as Belial started to hurl the javelin, he had already slightly re-angled his body. When Belial launched her makeshift weapon, Cat Mask subtly adjusted his standing position enough for the javelin to whiff past his left ear. It missed him by less than a millimeter, making Belial's eyes widen to the size of saucers as the javelin sailed miles into the distance, never to be seen again.

He dodged?!

That was impossible! How could he have seen the attack coming and formulated the perfect response in a single second?

Several possible answers appeared in her head.

He was like her, with an impossibly flexible body.

He was a speedster who could move and react to the world around him with impossible timing.

He was a *precog* who could see the future.

Maybe even Jason Hiro gave him information on Belial. There was his Heroic title... *Archseer*. It was such a specific word. It implied some form of prophetic power... was that possible?

Belial didn't have time to ponder what Cat Mask's inhuman dodging capabilities meant. His gun snapped in her direction and he fired.

Despite her shock, Belial still reacted without hesitation. Her body 'exploded', splitting apart in fifteen different directions as if a bomb had gone off inside her chest. She instantly became a writhing mass of poorly-attached body parts; impossible for any human to predict their movements.

RIIIP!

The bullet tore through Belial's heart. Her 'impossible to predict' movement patterns were instantly seen through, and she coughed blood as the bullet passed through her vital organ.

"Ugh!!"

Belial quickly reformed her body. She pressed her palm against her chest to heal her injury, but her speed slowed as a result.

At that moment, Bael leaped into the air. He jumped at the sniper tower where Cat Mask stood, Big Bonk swinging overhead in a downward arc.

"Hey fucko, pick on a fella yer own size!" Bael roared.

The Duke of Pain slammed Big Bonk down into the sniper tower, smashing it into rubble. He grinned, knowing he had just felled another Hero.

At that moment, just to Lucifer's right...

Foop!

Cat Mask reappeared!

Belial's heart stopped. She looked at him in horror.

Lucifer also sensed the threat. Still unable to breathe, she shakily turned to face him, only to see the butt of his rifle hurtling toward her face.

Thump!!!

Cat Mask bashed the Emperor of Providence with all his strength, pulverizing her nose and sending her flying. She crashed into the Haven's wall and broke through it, leaving Belial's jaw gaping.

Enhanced strength?! Seven Hells, he hits almost as hard as me! Just who is this Hero? And was that teleportation he used, or was it super-speed?!

Cat Mask snapped his head toward Belial.

Foop!

He teleported again, appearing before the Emperor of Passion while swinging his weapon at her.

But Belial was ready. She snapped her fist at his face.

Foop!

He teleported again, dodging the attack!

Belial's counter attack whiffed, leaving her exposed for half a breath. Her reward was a violent impact to the back of her head, sending her sprawling to the ground.

Still injured from the bullet to her heart, Belial hadn't quite healed back to her optimal state, and that strike to the back of her head fully convinced her... this Hero was no joke! Cat Mask was terrifying!

"Buh-BAEL!!" Belial coughed.

Cat Mask teleported again. But this time, he didn't appear with his weapon raised to strike Belial. Instead, he struck at... nothing?

Cat Mask swung his gun like an idiot, whiffing the empty air. He stumbled slightly and looked confused, only to shake his head and look around, spotting Belial once more.

What was that? Why did he attack nothing? Could it be... Abby? Belial deduced.

Still injured, and more than a little dazed, Belial gritted her teeth. She leaped to her feet, dodging when Cat Mask swung again. This time, she focused solely on survival. She couldn't afford to counter-attack when facing this unknown Trueborn and expose a weakness again, not while she was injured. She didn't have time to heal herself, and Lucifer's status was unknown.

Bael finally arrived. Having recovered from failing to kill the Trueborn, he appeared madder than ever. He swung Big Bonk in a wide arc, causing the multi-ton flail to smash into several surviving human troopers, shredding their bodies into meaty chunks. The flail blew through the bathroom walls and shattered the structure into powder before arcing around to fly at Cat Mask and Belial.

The Emperor of Passion jumped. She leaped into the air to avoid the incoming attack, but Cat Mask simply bent backward at the waist as if he were doing a limbo dance. The

deadly flail's chain passed over his chest harmlessly, and Cat Mask pivoted his gun to aim up at Belial.

BLAM!

A bullet fired from the barrel and flew at her. Her eyes shrunk to pinpricks, and she twisted in midair to try to avoid it, but the damn thing instead tore through her stomach as if it were paper, ripping out her entrails and badly injuring her again!

"Ah!" Belial half-choked, half-gasped. She fell to the ground and struck the concrete like a sack of potatoes, writhing in pain as she struggled to draw breath.

The human's gun couldn't shoot very quickly. It had a long reload requirement, and it was huge and unwieldy, but in return it made for an excellent makeshift club in close-quarters combat, and its piercing power was ungodly! Even her hardened Emperor skin and bones offered no protection from the rifle's bullets.

Bael retracted Big Bonk. He glowered for a split second at the human laying on his back, but then Cat Mask shoved himself off the ground and performed a makeshift backflip by using the butt of his gun as an anchor against the floor.

Just when Belial thought the situation couldn't get any worse, Cat Mask snapped his fingers.

Jason Hiro suddenly appeared right beside him.

Belial's eyes widened.

Not just self-teleportation, but the teleportation of others? They'd been played!

Jason Hiro laughed uproariously. "Hahaha, not bad, dad! You did well teaching these pathetic demons a lesson, but I guess that's to be expected. They aren't sending their best! Just a bunch of weaklings!"

"Hey!" Bael roared, his attention refocusing on the scrawny little Trueborn who dared to mouth off in front of him. "What'd you say punk? You wanna have a go??"

"So what if I do? A mere Duke thinks himself my equal?" Jason asked in a rather flamboyant manner. "My dad already beat the asses of two Emperors. You're no threat to me, Duke of Pain! I know all your abilities! I'm the Archseer, HAHAHA!!"

While Jason ran his yap, Belial hurriedly healed herself. She continued to lay on the ground while allowing Bael to draw the Hero's attention.

God, his voice is so grating! Belial thought. *What an annoying loudmouth! But at least his idiocy is buying me a little time... and it seems Cat Mask is his father? That confirms Ose's guess from before!*

Bael charged at the two Heroes without regard for his own safety. Given his invincible body, Jason and Cat Mask were unlikely to seriously injure, let alone kill him. Thus, he did the smartest thing an idiot like him could come up with and drew their attention by charging in.

Belial climbed to her feet. She had finally healed all her injuries, but her battle intent had fallen dramatically. Even with Bael assisting her, she didn't think they could easily kill both Heroes. Maybe the boy, but...

[Belial. You and Bael need to leave.] Ose suddenly said, her voice transmitting from somewhere nearby. Belial could vaguely sense her presence, but she wasn't sure where she was.

"Huh? Right now?" Belial asked.

[My mother is out of commission. She fainted from lack of air. Murmur retrieved her body. Right now, Gressil and Abby are carrying me to safety while I send my Astral Form back to you. There are many humans on the way. Get out of there while you still can!]

Belial's expression darkened. If Abby, Ose, and Gressil had left along with Murmur and Lucifer, than she was left behind with only Bael to offer protection.

Now she definitely didn't think the two of them could win. Bael might not die, but it was certainly possible to pin him down, ensnare him, maybe even incapacitate and imprison him. That would be a huge blow to demonkind's fighting power.

"Bael!" Belial shouted. "We need to go!"

Belial turned to look at Bael. She stared in shock as the so-called Archseer took Bael on without Cat Mask's help. Despite clearly lacking the strength to inflict any real damage on the Duke of Pain, Jason wielded his bo staff with alarming competency. He spun it around himself, striking Bael's ears and eyes, slapping it against Bael's ass in a humiliating manner, and batting away Bael's hands and arms when the powerful Duke drew too close.

"Dammit! Ow, fuck, you little shit! Ow!" Bael bellowed, wincing as another end of the staff struck his ear and slightly dazed him. "You fucker! C'mere, brat! Ugly duckling!

OWW!!"

The young man held his own. Belial couldn't help but look at him in a daze. His movements were fast and fluid. He fought like a seasoned warrior, proving that while he might speak like an idiot, he had the combat acumen to back up his words.

"What's the matter? Can't land a hit on me?" Jason jeered, taunting Bael mercilessly. "That's because I'm the great Archseer! I can see the future, and none of the upcoming timelines involve you winning! Just give it up and beg daddy for mercy, you fat bastard!"

Bael's angry words slowed down. He started speaking less and less as fear started to mix into his rage.

He remembered a time, long long ago.

A time when another warrior, far more capable in battle techniques than him, broke his body, his mind, and his spirit.

That man's name was *Jepthath*, the Illuminator.

Bael never forgot the horror he felt when Jepthath disassembled him, beating him down not with strength, but superior melee techniques.

This kid... he had a shadow of that ancient monster in him!

Bael felt as if his most feared rival had returned from beyond the grave. The Duke of Pain lacked a robust enough vocabulary to describe just how terrified it made him feel to be unable to touch a hair on such a seemingly puny Hero's head.

Jason was weak. His strikes only hurt Bael when they struck his most sensitive areas, and even those hurt about as much as a man flicking a child's ear. It stung a little, but the sensation only intensified Bael's fear, because he couldn't even reflect that paltry level of pain back at his younger adversary.

After a particularly brutal strike struck Bael's eyes, he suddenly jumped backward and rubbed his face. His vision cleared up, and he looked at the young man in horror.

"Nah... NAH! I ain't- I ain't doin' this! Screw you, man, SCREW YOU!"

Bael turned and ran. He rushed past Belial, and she only recovered a moment later to see Jason and Cat Mask charging at her.

"The demons are escaping!" Jason shouted. "Let's at least kill this one!"

Belial reacted. She darted away, chasing after Bael into the forest.

At the same time, a figure suddenly flickered past her. All Belial saw was a blur of white as something raced at Jason and slammed into his chest, kicking him backward and sending him flying!

"Ugh!!"

Jason coughed as he crashed into the wall and sunk to the ground, his chest crying out in pain.

There, an unlikely savior appeared. Ose, the Baron of Infiltration, stood between the Heroes and her seniors.

"Run!" Ose shouted back at Belial. "Take Bael and go. I'll hold them off!"

No longer in her Astral Body, Ose arrived back on the scene ready to fight with her full physical strength. She focused her attention on both Heroes, and Belial only hesitated for a second before nodding and continuing to run.

"They're after YOU, Ose!" Belial shouted back. "Don't take any risks!"

Ose narrowed her eyes.

"I know." She muttered under her breath.

By now, some of the human soldiers had managed to pick themselves back up. Reinforcements would arrive from abroad, and others would emerge from underground.

It wouldn't be long before the situation turned completely hopeless.

Even so, Ose sneered.

"Cat Mask and the Archseer, huh?" Ose hissed. "Father and son? Let's see if you're as scary as you seem."

Jason pulled himself to his feet and clutched his injured chest. "D-dad! It's Ose! She's the one! You have to take her down!"

Cat Mask nodded.

"My son thinks you're demonkind's greatest asset. Says he saw a future where your powers brought humanity to ruin. Too bad you came here to die early. Now your wretched species won't survive to witness that future."

Ose chuckled.

"We'll see about that, *Heroes*."

Part 635: She's Only a Baron!

Recommended Listening

January 21st, 2021. 5AM.

Ose, the Baron of Infiltration. Jason Hiro, the 'Archseer'. Cat Mask, an unknown enigma.

Illuminati reinforcements trickled onto the scene as these three powerhouses faced each other down. They took aim with their guns, but before they could start shooting at their demonic enemy, Jason Hiro suddenly raised a fist.

"Hold your fire. This demon is mine and my father's alone! I WILL have a demon corpse to mount as a trophy, and I won't let any of you weaklings steal my glory!"

Jason stood up. Ose's flying kick had sent him smashing into a wall, but it didn't escape her notice that he wasn't badly injured. Clearly, his heroic powers involved some sort of defensive boost. He still massaged his chest and seemed to be a little winded, but her assassination attempt hadn't taken him out for good.

Ose snorted. "Looking down on me just because I'm a Baron? That will be your LAST mistake!"

Jason had fought Ose in the future. He had faced her when she was an Emperor, far stronger than she was now. The simple baseline increases in power, speed, and durability from Baron to Duke to Emperor could not be underestimated. The Ose of this era was much less scary than the one he knew 100,000 years from now. To say nothing of what all those millennia may have taught her future self in terms of battle experience and worldly knowledge...

But Ose was wrong about one thing. Jason did not underestimate her. Not at all.

She was *Ghost*. She was humanity's greatest enemy. From what he had heard, she alone had been responsible for at least half the circumstances leading up to humanity's ultimate defeat! And that was while she was still only a Baron!

He would never make the mistake of treating her like a side-character.

Even so, Jason grinned like an idiot. "A mistake?! Come on then, you weak little woman! Show the Archseer, humanity's greatest Trueborn, what you can do!

Hahahaha!!!"

Ose's body snapped forward like an arrow loosed from a bow. She flew at Jason in a straight line so quickly that he couldn't even process her approach.

THUMP!

Ose spun her body at the last second and slammed her fist into the side of Jason's head, sending him careening to the right. His vision whirled wildly as he slammed against the ground, bounced, then spun multiple times in a row before crashing into a nearby Illuminati reinforcement who had just arrived. The impact of flesh against flesh broke multiple bones inside that man's body and knocked him unconscious as well.

Ose sneered. She turned to pursue the foe she'd just send flying, only for a flicker of energy to materialize behind her.

She ducked!

Ose moved with frightening speed, anticipating Cat Mask's teleportation as he swung the butt of his gun at the spot where her head just was. Instead, he whiffed the attack, and Ose swept her leg at his, intending to send him sprawling to the ground.

While Cat Mask's attack may have missed, he didn't fall for this trap. He anticipated her counter, then responded by hopping into the air, teleporting above her, and stomping his feet down at her head.

Ose's body flickered to the side. Cat Mask's feet passed through where she was just crouching and struck the concrete.

"Not bad." Ose hissed. "You're not very fast, but you're good at reading other people's movements."

Hideki Hiro narrowed his eyes under his mask. Ose naturally couldn't see this, but she sensed some tension in his movements as he realized she wasn't just speaking idle words.

Ose was a genius. She could uncover clues about people through the subtlest of movements, via the way they hesitated before speaking, and by the way in which they fought.

She was sussing him out; trying to determine what all his powers were.

That was the real reason Ose came here. Not to fight the two Trueborn for the sake of killing them, but mainly to collect intelligence. If she could take one or both of them out,

that would simply be a juicy bonus.

What a terrifying foe!

In an instant, Ose pounced at Cat Mask again. She charged him at the speed of light, sending a kick flying at his head, but he anticipated this attack and shifted his body slightly to the right. However, the instant her kick barely missed him, a deafening thunderclap exploded from the sole of her shoes, stunning Cat Mask and forcing him to teleport away.

He flickered to the side and reeled for a moment, his ears nearly rupturing from the sound. Ose quickly picked out his new position, and her eyes narrowed.

Intelligence is good and all, but if I can kill one of them... THAT WOULD BE EVEN BETTER!

She zipped toward Cat Mask, ready to deliver a killing blow. Suddenly, Jason teleported into her path, his bo staff raised in a defensive position.

Thump!

Ose's fist struck the staff, but it held firm. Despite seemingly being made of wood, she instantly realized this was not the case! It was harder than demonstone... impossibly so!

Jason used the impact of Ose's fist against his staff to reverse its momentum and snap the other end up at her chin, but she simply bent her head backward and allowed it to miss by a millimeter. The very instant the staff missed, Ose rocked forward on the ball of her heels and slammed her forehead against Jason's.

She headbutted him!

The unexpected impact of Ose's skull battered Jason backward and sent him tumbling onto his father. Luckily, his body's weird resilience protected him from suffering a serious concussion, but it still threw him off-balance as the two Heroes fell atop one another.

This is impossible! Jason thought. *It doesn't feel like Baron Ose is any weaker than she was as an Emperor. Her reaction speed is at a level even my dad can't keep up with while using his time slowdowns and rewinding tricks, let alone me! Was Ose always this deadly?*

Jason and his father had only traded a few attacks with Ose, but it was the son who realized how his original plan to respond to her threat with the maximum force still didn't take her seriously enough. She was way beyond what he had anticipated.

In truth, the evolution from Baron to Emperor didn't really grant Ose many new core abilities. It simply improved her raw mana output, and her body's physical capabilities. In terms of deadliness, she possessed the capacity to be as frightening as many Dukes and Emperors of this era!

Jason grinned like a madman. He leaped backward off his father, planted his staff in the ground, and yanked himself to his feet.

"You're not bad, Ose! Not bad at all!" Jason proclaimed in a manner most gaudy. He pointed a finger at her and puffed out his chest. "You might only be a Baron, but you're worth me using at least... thirteen percent of my power!"

Ose didn't look at Jason with mocking eyes. She stared at him in the same way a deadly serpent might, assessing his true threat and perhaps seeing through his words into the parts unspoken.

"You talk a lot." Ose said calmly. "And you say more than you think you do."

The corner of Jason's eye flickered. His smile faltered, ever so slightly.

What did Ose mean by that?

Cat Mask suddenly jumped up. He sent a powerful punch flying at the Demon Baron, but she simply spun in place, slapped his hand, and redirected his momentum. Then she sent a palm strike flying at his mask.

Jason's father bent his head at the last second. He avoided Ose's retaliatory strike, then batted her hand away with his elbow.

In an instant, the two started striking at each other, reacting and attacking at speeds that left the Illuminati soldiers gobsmacked! Palms crashed against palms. Arms became entangled, thunderclaps exploded, lightning bolts were followed by bullets that would have killed Ose if they struck, but they didn't.

Despite this flurry of attacks, neither combatant managed to injure the other. Jason watched with a mixture of awe and horror as he realized his father's empowered body and temporal slowdown abilities only barely made him able to match Ose. In terms of speed-reactions, in terms of sudden and instantaneous movements, Ose completely outclassed him. If Cat Mask didn't have the ability to slow his perception of time down to an absolute crawl, he would have lost a thousand times across a thousand battles!

Despite being unable to land a killing blow on the tenacious masked Hero, Ose did not lose her cool. Her battle intent always smoldered at a completely stable level. Unbeknownst to Jason and his father, Ose not only fought Cat Mask, but also kept a careful eye on the other human soldiers aiming guns at her. Though none of them fired, she was ready to escape the instant the situation turned dire.

In the middle of Ose and Cat Mask's furious melee, Jason teleported behind Ose, pinning her between himself and his father. Jason spun up his bo staff and swung it at her hips, but Ose flickered to the side, dodged the staff, then flickered back and karate chopped Jason's lungs. His vision went black as she blew the breath out of his body and sent him doubling over, while at the same time she redirected one of Cat Mask's kicks at Jason's face.

"Shit!" Cat Mask cursed. He readjusted his kick mid-movement and missed Jason's head, but Ose finally punished him for this mistake by flickering behind him, raising both fists, and slamming them down on the back of his head.

Thump!

She battered Cat Mask downward, collapsing him atop his son.

For a few seconds, the battlefield went still.

Ose breathed evenly. She wasn't winded at all. She had also completely trashed both Heroes, yet she came to realize that even if she landed her strongest attacks, they were clearly protected by some sort of invisible armor, or perhaps defensive enchantments. Jason himself kept getting up time and time again, yet his body appeared so frail that she realized this must be a deception.

Ose's mind moved quickly. She evaluated countless possible scenarios at a speed that would make many Psion Brain Enhancers look at her with deep respect.

Then, she made an important tactical choice.

She fled!

Ose abruptly became a beam of white light. She launched herself like a rocket diagonally into the northern skies, disappearing behind the clouds and leaving her dazed Heroic foes to pick themselves up.

"Sh-shit!" Jason shouted. "She's getting away! Fucking hell, stop her, you idiots!!"

The soldiers blinked. They started moving again, contacting their superiors to try and triangulate Ose's position.

Unfortunately, they failed.

Ose was fast. Lightning fast. She had spent hundreds of years developing a combat system focused on punishing opponents who were slower than her, and she made good use of that system today against two otherwise formidable foes.

The only reason she had to depart without finishing the job was because she was too weak to kill them! Perhaps in the future, she would rectify this shortcoming.

Jason barked orders. He sent Illuminati guards in every direction, fanning out to check the woods. At the same time, he stormed over to one of the commanders who had somehow miraculously survived the initial demonic onslaught.

"YOU!!" Jason roared. "Is this all the god damn Illuminati is capable of?! I expected better!!"

"Sir?" The man asked, flinching under Jason's tirade.

"What the fuck do you mean *sir*? Sir, WHAT?!" Jason shouted even louder. "You let her get away! Why didn't you shoot Ose while she was trying to escape?! Is this all just a fucking joke to you?!"

Never had the poor man felt so aggrieved. *Why are you yelling at me? You told us not to fire! This is your fault, you stupid, moronic, idiot of a Trueborn!*

But he didn't dare vocalize those words. Jason may have gotten his ass kicked by a mere Baron, but he was clearly in such a rage that he might snap and pulverize the commander into meat paste if the guy pissed him off!

"I-I'm sorry, sir... it w-won't... happen again..." The man said, trying not to cry pitiful tears over the unfairness of the situation.

At that moment, the man received a transmission through his earpiece that made him want to curl up into a ball and die. Feeling even more aggrieved, he looked at Jason with eyes begging for sympathy.

"S-sir...?"

"That's LORD ARCHSEER to you, weakling!" Jason shouted back.

"Yes, Lord Archseer, sir... we've just received word... Baron Ose hacked our internal computer network. She stole hundreds of thousands of files. In-including the ones... detailing your Heroic Abilities."

Jason jolted backward. His eyes buzzed as if he'd been struck by thunder.

"She DID?! You fucking IMBECILES! All you Illuminati morons! How could you let her do that?! You told me you had really good anti-hacking technology and all that fancy stuff!! If the demons know all my powers, they'll be able to plot against me! How could you screw up this badly?!"

Jason stomped from side to side. He grabbed and pulled his hair, raging at the pure incompetency of the Illuminati and how painfully useless and unreliable they were. All the while, the soldiers looked at him as if they were looking at the most incompetent asshole on the planet.

Why is he blaming us? We told him not to put those files on the network! This is all his fault, not ours!

Inside the Haven, Victoria Rothschild slumped at the security camera desk. Her expression was one of defeat.

"Gods... he's such a fool... I can't believe the ancestors chose to believe in him. We're doomed. Now the demons know everything about him. I just can't believe how little accountability he's willing to take for his own actions."

Claire sat next to Victoria. She sipped some tea from a cup, and looked surprisingly unperturbed.

"Mmm-hmm, yup, he's definitely an idiot, cousin. Definitely. Mhm."

Her sarcasm went undetected. Victoria's doom and gloom was too serious to pay attention to any irregularities in Claire's tone of voice. Claire ended up shrugging her shoulders and sipping more tea.

* * *

Unnoticed by the humans, a phantasmal body levitated in the sky. Ose, having escaped in an instant, quickly hid herself in the nearby forest, placing her body within some dense foliage before sending her Astral Form back to the scene. She carefully entered the surface level of the Haven once more, observing all of Jason Hiro's ranting and raving, as well as

the dismal expressions of the guards on scene. As if confirming something to herself, she nodded slowly, then returned back to her body before leaving again.

Some time later, Ose regrouped with the other demons. They perked up when she approached, but all of them seemed to be in low spirits. Lucifer was up and about again, with Belial being the most likely person to have extracted the bullet from her throat that had rendered her unconscious. Belial sat on a tree stump, Murmur sat up in a tree branch, and Abby sat on the ground, dejected. Ose only spotted her brother lurking behind a tree, out of sight, when she deliberately tried to locate him. He was talented at meekly blending into the background.

"Ose." Belial said, from her spot on the tree stump. "Tell me you have good news."

Ose didn't respond for a few seconds. She looked around the group, seeming to ponder something unspoken.

"It could be good news." Ose said, stroking her chin slowly. "Or it might not. I managed to steal the majority of the Illuminati's files. In terms of reconnaissance, I'd say this mission should be graded a complete success. I initiated battle against the Archseer and Cat Mask, and I used the data I obtained to cross-correlate it with their performance. Everything about Jason lined up perfectly."

"It did?" Belial asked. "Well, at least we know our enemy better."

Belial lowered her head in relief, but Ose narrowed her eyes.

"Assuming the files are to be believed, the Archseer is a Hero who possesses an ability referred to as Dream Eating. When he sleeps, he is able to enter a dream world related tangentially to ours. He can 'devour' dream knowledge about combat, warfare, tactics, technology, and all sorts of other things. Most notably, he can also obtain information about his enemies... as well as knowledge of the future."

Belial frowned. She lifted her head again and met Ose's eyes. "You sound unconvinced."

"I am simply working off a hypothesis." Ose said, softening her expression. "Let's say there is currently a... five percent chance... portions of this information may have been be falsified. Either deliberately or accidentally."

Lucifer stood nearby, leaning against a tree. She looked at her daughter curiously.

"Meaning?"

"Meaning some of the Archseer's abilities may not be what they seem, or what the internal files claim." Ose said. "The Dream Eating is likely true, but some of these other data points are deceptive. Take for example one entry which lists him as having enhanced durability."

Ose crossed her arms.

"I believe this to be a deliberate lie. Jason Hiro is certainly durable, but that power is *not* his own. I believe he was augmented by another Hero during my battle. Perhaps one of the Heroic Ancestors."

Abby looked at Ose. She was uncharacteristically somber compared to her usual self. "Those were only two of the Heroes though. We still have a third to deal with."

Ose blinked her eyes. She slowly shook her head.

"No. I was wrong before. There are only *two* Trueborn."

"Only two?" Belial asked. "Wait, what makes you say that?"

Ose once again paused. She looked around at her comrades and smirked.

"Oh, you lot haven't figured it out yet? You are truly too slow of mind. Think for a moment. What reason did I give for there being another yet-unknown Hero in addition to Cat Mask but prior to Jason's arrival?"

The other demons metaphorically scratched their head. Surprisingly, it was Murmur, sitting up on a tree branch, who offered her take.

"Teleportation..." Murmur said quietly.

"Very good, Emperor Murmur!" Ose praised. "That's right. Cat Mask was estimated to be a Hero who possessed some sort of perfect accuracy ability when it came to firearms, as well as quick reaction speeds. I confirmed both of those during the battle, but you should have ALL seen him teleporting not only himself, but Jason Hiro around."

Ose held up her hands.

"So... there it is! It turns out Cat Mask has been carefully hiding his ability to teleport all these years, waiting for an opportunity to catch us off-guard. Now that we know this, we can piece together that he was the only Hero until recently, and now his son has also been Uplifted. That means the Heroic Aura *has* somehow become a bloodline ability, but

so far there are only two inheritors. Cat Mask and Jason Hiro are likely the son and grandson of Harold Whittaker. We have one less target to take out."

A collective sigh of relief went up among the demons. Ose's words truly released some of the pressure they had been feeling.

"But don't underestimate this Archseer." Ose warned. "He may seem stupid and oafish, but the fact I was able to obtain all these files is extremely suspicious. I believe Ancestor Mildred is secretly helping him!"

"Mad Madam Mildred?" Lucifer asked.

"That's right, mother." Ose explained. "There is a plot brewing. I am not certain of all the details, but we must exercise extreme caution around the ancient Wise Ones. Solomon, Mildred, Nebuchadnezzar, and Hammurabi are not to be trifled with."

She continued. "I believe Mildred planted false information regarding Jason's abilities. She is trying to deceive us, to give us a false impression of his strength. In reality, he might be two, even three times stronger than what he displayed today. Should anyone here encounter him in the future, assume he might be hiding other abilities, either equally as deadly, or even more so."

After concluding her immediate analysis of the recent battle, Ose straightened her posture and popped her back.

"Let's call this mission a success for now. But Belial? You and I need to have a talk."

Belial raised an eyebrow. "About what?"

"About me paying a visit to the First Emperor." Ose said cryptically. "There is a *very* important matter I need to bring up with Satan."

Belial and Ose stared at one another for a few seconds. They seemed to exchange words with their mere expressions.

Belial looked down, closed her eyes, and nodded.

"I believe he will be... agreeable to what you seek."

Ose grinned. "*Good*. It's in demonkind's best interests. That much should be obvious, after today."

Part 636: MindCores

January 21st, 2021. 8AM, Location Unknown.

In a spatial tear somewhere within Earth's vicinity, a small room filled with computer monitors sat, disconnected from the outside universe. In here, a pair of spiritual life forms stood, male and female, their identities being Jepthath and Mildred. Also inside this computer room, two more physical-bodied men stood. One of them was Cat Mask. The other was...

"Hahaha! Now that was a good fight!" Jason boasted, puffing out his chest in a manner most audacious. "Great work coordinating the teleport network, Mildred! You really saved my dad's ass multiple times! Not me though. I was totally fine!!"

Hideki Hiro looked at his son with only the faintest expression of bemusement. "Jason, this whole persona thing you've made is getting to be a bit... grating. Can you fix yourself now?"

"What do you mean?" Jason asked, visibly aggrieved. "I like the way I feel! I feel awesome! I'm confident, ready to kick some ass, and best of all, I barely even notice all those old depressing thoughts about my dead wife. I want to feel like this all the time!"

Mildred gently shook her head. "No, you do not, dear boy. You have done nothing more than deliberately delude yourself. It is not healthy for you to remain in such a state of mind."

Jason frowned. "But now I get to act like the Hero I'm supposed to be. You should have seen those demons! I scared them shitless!"

"That was me." Hideki said blandly. "They were scared of me. Come on, son. Just drop the act now. It's exhausting listening to you ramble like that."

Jason swiveled his head to look at his father, Mildred, and finally Jepthath.

"What about you, great 'Illuminator'? You think I'm totally badass, right?!"

"You are annoying me. All of us." Jepthath stated flatly.

"Oh. Well. Alright then." Jason said, finally sensing that his 'awesomeness' wasn't having the effect he intended.

The 'Archseer' sighed. He pouted for a minute, then begrudgingly uttered a Word of Power.

"**...Normalize.**"

Instantly, his expression changed. His posture loosened, and he stopped puffing out his chest. He seemed to sag down, shrinking two inches, and becoming a lot more ordinary-feeling than before.

"So I'm back to myself." Jason said dryly. "Mildred. Jepthath. Thanks for reminding me to snap out of it."

"Anytime, dear boy." Mildred said politely. "Project Great Deceiver appears to have been a huge success. The demons have obtained false intelligence about your abilities. They now believe you to possess completely incorrect abilities... but you must be careful. Ose is extremely intelligent, and she already guessed that some of the intelligence she stole was falsified. She has erroneously begun to believe this was my doing, so at least she doesn't suspect you as being the true mastermind."

Jason frowned. "Did Spynet 2.0 record her movements after she departed?"

"It did." Mildred assured him. "I have not only reviewed all the footage, but I've cut things down to the most relevant parts. Take a look."

Jason nodded. He summoned a couple of chairs for himself and his father, but Cat Mask waved his hand. "I already saw the files. Just watch them yourself. I'm going to go take a nap. Wake me up once the briefing is over."

"Alright. Thanks, dad." Jason said, watching for a moment as his father strode out the room into a prepared side-chamber.

Their current location was a secret dimension not dissimilar to Chrona in the future. However, unlike Chrona, this secret realm was not nearly as large, and it was only a temporary shelter. It moved at a mere ten times the outside universe's speed so it would remain effortlessly stable. Jason did not want his future secret base located in the same orbit as Earth, especially as Heaven was already located here and it was possible the Demons and Volgrim might detect it.

In the near future, Jason would make a new secret realm elsewhere in the Milky Way, somewhere nobody would be able to find it. But that would come a little later.

For now, he sat down at the new Spynet, and proceeded to review the video files Mildred had collected. Unfortunately, Ose might not be a telepath, but her higher cognitive functions were essentially hidden behind a cryptographic barrier. Jason could not peer into her thoughts; only listen to her words and extrapolate based on her body movements.

He watched as she returned to the scene of the battle in her Astral Body. Unbeknownst to Ose, Jason had anticipated she would do just this, and had planned a performance to deceive her, thinking he was enraged that the 'secret files' about his 'Dream Eating' powers were stolen.

Naturally, all of that information was false, but the great trick was that it was false in just the right way that he could hide his true abilities of Wordsmithing.

Jason observed as Ose returned to the other demons. Ose explained to the others her misgivings, and this caused Jason's frown to deepen.

"She's sharp." Jason muttered. "She's already figured out that my powers aren't entirely what they seem. Given time, she might figure out the rest, but for now, she'll deliver falsified intelligence to Satan. That's exactly what we want."

"She also came to believe that your daughter didn't exist." Jepthath pointed out. "Cat Mask's 'teleportation powers' successfully tricked her into thinking Daisy and him were the same person."

"It'll buy us some time." Jason said. "As long as I can convince Daisy to be more careful with her teleportation, it will take the demons a lot longer to uncover her true identity. By then, we should have established more robust countermeasures."

Mildred watched the video along with Jason. She frowned several times.

"This Ose is truly frightening. She is fast in every way. Her reaction speeds and agility are nothing compared to her cerebral computational speeds. Personally, dear boy, I am not that quick-witted of a thinker. I am considered a Qualitative Thinker. In terms of raw mental computational speed, Ose exceeds my capabilities. Do not underestimate her."

Jason licked his lips. "I thought I overestimated her, but I was wrong. Ose was too fast. I had to use the fallback plan instead of actually killing her and Gressil. I didn't think killing a mere Baron would be so difficult, but it turned out Ose was only slightly less scary than the future version I fought."

Jason lowered his eyes to stare at the ground.

"I killed Ose in the future. At the time, it seemed effortless, but I had a lot of things going my way. I caught her off-guard, and she thought Bael's body was invincible; a falsehood I managed to exploit with my Pseudo Excalibur. I cut through her faster than she could react. If she had known my blade was capable of harming her, let alone killing her, she would have prepared counter-measures. I probably would have failed my assassination attempt. The Ose of this era is under no illusion that a threat like me can't kill her, so she will always fight more defensively than we expect."

Jason carefully analyzed the battle, even going so far as to replay the recorded video feed from multiple different angles.

"My Archseer persona fought too stupidly. He didn't use his brains at all." Jason said, treating his alternate self as if they were a completely different person. "That's good if the goal is to deceive the demons into thinking I'm a musclebrained moron, but if we actually want to kill any Demon Emperors, my other self will end up getting me killed instead."

"This was only a trial run." Mildred clarified. "Project Great Deceiver succeeded in the ways that mattered. Killing Ose and Gressil would have been excellent secondary goals, but right now, we need to capitalize on our information advantage. The demons will see the Archseer as less of a threat and focus more on your father. We should make sure Hideki shows up in public and draws as much attention as possible so that you have time to start amassing your arsenal of contingencies."

Jason leaned back in the chair. He sighed as he looked up at the ceiling.

"Alright. I think the first thing we need to do is get to work building my cerebral supercomputer."

Mildred curled up her lips in disgust. "Dear boy, are you really going to keep calling it that? Let's call it something more elegant, something that isn't such a mouthful. How about... *MindCore*?"

Jason narrowed his eyes at the ceiling. "That... hardly seems the most important thing to worry about right now."

"Oh, but it is!" Mildred protested. "Words have power! You should know that much. And 'Cerebral Supercomputer' hardly rolls off the tongue. Therefore, from now on, we shall refer to it as your MindCore!"

Jason blinked slowly. "Alright. Sure. Whatever. MindCore it is. Let's just move on to what I mentioned before."

"Alright." Mildred said. "While you built this time-enhanced realm, I spent some of my energy on coming up with a few different designs for your MindCore. Would you like to peruse them?"

Jason raised an eyebrow as he turned his head to look at her.

"Huh? Designs? What do you mean? Just help me recreate the MindCore I had in the future."

Mildred scoffed. "Brat! You won't let me access your future memories! How can this beautiful bombshell remake something you won't let her see? Besides, you speak as if there is only one way to optimize such a fantastical concept as a MindCore. There are far more ways than one!"

Jason sat up in the chair. He looked at Mildred with eyes full of intrigue.

"Really? What do you mean?"

Mildred didn't respond with words. Instead, she walked over to the Spynet console and changed several screens to show different types of server designs, placements, and positions, some of which looked human, others demonic, angelic, and even outright alien.

"Listen here, dear boy... the computer you described to me was one designed around prediction. It allowed you to predict things based on contextual clues, including analyzing how other people moved, twitched, where they looked, the words they used when responding, and so on. It seems to have been made to enhance your powers of prediction to the utmost limit. Not a bad way to build such a device, but terribly limited in other areas."

Mildred changed the projection. She revealed a much more evil and sinister design, one Jason immediately felt revulsion toward. It was dripping with demonic imagery, pentagrams, and other details that made his skin crawl.

"What the hell is this?" Jason asked.

Mildred shrugged in a funny way. "*Hell* is a good term. This is the HellProphet redesign of your former MindCore. You see, Jason, you limited yourself when you designed your first MindCore around elevating the predictive abilities of your 'Smithy' demonic persona, yet did not take demonic design applications into account. If you had

done so, you could have doubled; no, even tripled the qualitative predictive ability of that MindCore."

Jason looked disgusted. "This is repulsive! Why would I install something demonic in my brain? Whose side are you on, Mildred??"

Jepthath nodded. "I agree. This is an abomination against all of creation!"

Mildred *tut-tutted* at the two men. "It is a wonderful combination of magical and physical technology! Don't let your hatred of demonkind blind you to superior design solutions, dear boys! Look here."

Mildred zoomed in on the server composition of the HellProphet MindCore.

"Your approach was entirely too conventional, dear boy. Half-hearted at best. What I'm proposing is a complete redesign using demonic principles. Infernal probability matrices housed within soulbound algorithms, core processors forged from abyssal metals. Your human design merely scratched the surface. A proper HellProphet would use pentagrammic neural pathways with bloodstone computational nodes to siphon temporal insights. Far more powerful, though not without certain... costs."

"Costs." Jason said blandly. "What, like Satan obtaining my soul when I fall asleep? Hard pass."

"Nothing as severe as that." Mildred chuckled. "I was more referring to a constant, dull headache even your Wordsmithing wouldn't be able to get rid of. But the benefits would be immense! Your powers of prediction would skyrocket!"

"I'm not shoving demonic shit into my skull. End of story." Jason replied, visibly unimpressed. "Especially not if it gives me a constant headache. I have enough of that as-is."

Mildred looked at him for a moment, then shook her head. "Oh, fine then! Let's move on. I do have several other suggestions, and time's a-wasting!"

She summoned another projection of a completely different MindCore. "This one should look much more pleasant to you."

Jason blinked. The second MindCore was very obviously angelic in design. It was colored white and gold, and there were winged patterns and designs on the various server cores. It all felt a bit gaudy and overdesigned, but at least it didn't appear outright evil like the HellProphet did.

"This is the OmniRecord." Mildred explained. "It was the easiest MindCore to design, because it's basically just Solomon's Crown. If you want to perfectly mimic the functionality of his Crown without having to rely on that old trickster, this is a fine alternative."

Jason nodded in realization. "So this will give me a perfect memory, infinite data storage, rapid learning capabilities, all that other jazz?"

"Precisely." Mildred affirmed. "The angelic designs are not merely aesthetic in nature. I built it with celestial datacores that never degrade and memory crystals synchronized in perfect harmony. This may surprise you, but this is effectively how Solomon's Crown looks at the deepest level. It is a nearly perfect mimicry of what Archangel Camael created."

Jason's eyes metaphorically flashed with insight. "Doesn't this mean I could just create a new Crown of my own? If this is a mimicry of it, then I don't even need to build a MindCore at all! I can just make an artifact."

"That won't work." Mildred said, crossing her arms dismissively. "These are MindCores... *not* artifacts. Artifacts are much smaller and more compact. I am... not capable of creating such wonders. I don't even know how Camael makes them, but perhaps you might be able to pick her brain and find out for yourself, if you're so interested. However, if you could find another person with a Mind Realm as expansive as yours, you could take the time to build them one of my suggested MindCores. Then you'd have two MindCore powerhouses."

Jason thought about this for a moment.

"Are you implying not just anyone has a Mind Realm 'big enough' to fit a MindCore?"

"You are a very unique individual." Mildred clarified. "Your powers are all based on imagination and comprehension. You might be a bit of a dullard, but your Mind Realm is far more expansive than most. Your father already effectively has a MindCore, via the melted-down Solomon's Crown implanted in him during his jaunts into future timelines. He is unable to accommodate much more within his Mind Realm. Your daughter Daisy *might* have room for a MindCore, but the vast majority of ordinary humans would not. Only truly intelligent individuals, or those gifted in spiritual power may have such capacity available. I would have to determine the circumstances on a case-by-case basis,

and it would take time to construct MindCores for each individual. Time we do not necessarily have, dear boy."

Mildred proceeded to reveal another MindCore design while Jason pondered her words.

"This one may be to your liking more than any others before and after. I have based this MindCore on my own powers. This is the GenesisFrame. It is a human-based design using principles you should be familiar with. It is highly focused on innovation, invention, and creativity. If you want to become a master of the new and exotic, no other MindCore I've come up with will surpass this one."

Jason immediately became intrigued. While the GenesisFrame lacked the predictive abilities he had used to don the identity of Smithy, it had new and unique concepts that greatly excited him.

"The GenesisFrame is not designed to be fast or efficient. It will not be useful in a battle involving speed, but it will be fantastic in applications of long-term strategic and macro-focused warfare. If you want to invent new technologies, come up with new ways to use your existing powers, and otherwise become a terrifying and self-sufficient Heroic powerhouse, I don't think you can go wrong with this MindCore."

Jason rubbed his chin thoughtfully. "It feels like this would make me a lot more like my wife from the future. She was always so creative, so inventive. She left me in the dust."

"That is possible, dear boy." Mildred said, puffing her chest out. "Your wife sounds like she was a real firecracker! Ah-ha-ha-ha!"

Jason's smile faded away. He nodded. "Yeah. She was."

A moment of silence followed. Mildred cleared her throat.

"Moving on. There's also this MindCore, which I have dubbed the QuantumReflex. This is based on monstrous biology, and focuses on instincts, particularly in combat. I designed this after seeing your pathetic battle against Ose. This will grant you thinking speeds far beyond the norm. Even Solomon would not be able to match your raw computational speed. You would be able to out-think all but the most fearsome Brain Enhancers, giving you the ability to think and react to any threat with a casual amount of effort. It would be as if you installed a Super Chrona inside your brain, functioning passively at all times."

Mildred smiled. "And there's a bonus! You would never need to sleep again! You would be active at all times, indefatigable, unrelenting. While it wouldn't necessarily do much for your creativity, you would be as smart, predictive, and creative as you are now, but a thousand times more efficient at what you already do. This is a solid all-around solution that would enhance you in all the important ways."

Jason nodded, but then he frowned. "I get it. But... this doesn't really solve any problems I need solving. It's just 'more of me' and I want to be *better* than I am now. Having the instincts of a combat god like Ose is exciting in a primal way, but humanity won't win the Energy Wars by me just being a faster version of myself. Do you have anything else?"

"One last MindCore option comes to mind." Mildred said with a nod. "I based it on the Titans. It is known as RealitySim, and it's exactly what you would expect."

She continued. "World-bearing computation arrays capable of modeling entire universes. Reality-modeling monoliths based on the vastness of Titan minds, containing echoes of worlds that once existed. You could simulate countless asynchronous scenarios with perfect fidelity to natural laws—or manipulate those laws if you wished."

"That sounds like some sort of Universim game or something." Jason commented.

"This is best thought of as a sidegrade or an alternate form of your original MindCore. It's designed to allow you to simulate countless scenarios based on known information. For example, did you find your battle against Ose frustrating? You could upload all known information about Ose, then simulate battles against her until you became an expert in combating her, before finally imprinting that knowledge into your bones. When next you fought, you would completely overwhelm her!"

Jason's eyes flashed. This was an extremely practical MindCore, one he could easily make great use of. It gave him all sorts of new capabilities, and it could even be used for conceptually inventing artifacts, testing them in an alternate 'universe', then finalizing those designs before crafting them back in reality.

He could even simulate great individuals like Solomon, Mildred, and other such Sentients, all for the sake of figuring out what they would do or create in a given situation.

"The RealitySim is really, really appealing to me." Jason concluded. "There's just one problem."

Mildred blinked. "And that would be?"

"It's based on Titans." Jason said, lowering his eyes.

He fell silent. Then he began to think.

Minutes passed.

Jason contemplated all the different options.

HellProphet. It's an improved version of my original MindCore, but the headache downside, and the fact it's based on demon technology makes it a no-go. Knowing my original version was so flawed makes me want to abandon the entire 'prediction' angle anyway.

OmniRecord. It's basically just Solomon's Crown. Can't go wrong with that. The old man already showed me the value of his crown countless times. Ah, but I don't have his Heroic powers. I can't copy anyone's memories just by touching them, and I also don't have the full backlog of information Solomon had stored after countless years of coming into contact with high-ranking humans, demons, and angels. I would be starting out fresh. This option is a lot less valuable as a result.

QuantumReflex. I could make good use of speed. Time is my greatest enemy. Simply doing what I already do, but faster, would give humanity and myself both an immense time boost to catch up. Being able to out-think enemies like Ose would also be great. But it doesn't really make me any smarter. That reduces its value a lot.

RealitySim. This one is truly amazing. It solves all my problems and gives me new and powerful ways to approach future issues. Unfortunately, it's a Titan design, which almost feels like a betrayal of the human species. For that reason...

Jason nodded slowly.

"I'm going to have to go with the GenesisFrame. I like that it's human in origin. I don't want to rely on a design that's demonic, angelic, monstrous, or Titan-based. Humans are good enough to defeat the other species. If I were to fall back to some other species' design, would that not already be tantamount to admitting my own species isn't versatile enough to win this war?"

"I agree!" Jepthath exclaimed, smiling proudly. "What a good decision, Wordsmith! Don't rely on the wicked weapons of the enemy, but the tools of your people. Humans are

creative. Inventive! We need only rely on our own brains to ascend to the apex ranks of cosmic power!"

Mildred didn't look totally convinced. "You seemed quite charmed by the RealitySim option."

"Only for a moment." Jason said, before quickly explaining his reasoning. "Let's just go with the GenesisFrame. Unless you have misgivings about it?"

Mildred smiled. "Of course not. It's based on this bedeviled temptress's abilities, after all! Ha-ha-ha-ha! How can you go wrong with using tried and true methods like the ones I have displayed?! Even better, you obtaining something similar to my cerebral powers will allow me to slack off a bit. I won't have to do all the creative thinking for you. Better to be self-sufficient, dear boy!"

Jason sighed with relief.

"I agree. Mildred, start drawing up detailed plans. I want to get this GenesisFrame up and running as soon as possible!"

Mildred gave him a big thumbs-up. "At once!"

She trotted over to the computers, then started rapidly typing, drawing, and sketching out plans for the GenesisFrame. As she did, Jason leaned back in his chair and closed his eyes, relaxing for a while.

"Heh, imagine giving up on my beauty sleep." Jason muttered to himself. "That alone disqualified the QuantumReflex from contention."

Part 637: Ose's Bugs

January 24th, 2021. 9AM, New York City.

Three days had passed since the battle at the Illuminati Haven. Belial dispersed her team, sending everyone off their separate ways. However, while Lucifer returned to one of her Hell's secret bases in Northern California, Ose remained with Belial. The two of them donned human disguises and took a strangely normal trip back to the eastern side of the states by flying aboard a human airplane. A Boeing 747, ideal for inter-continental flights, took them all the way to their destination in a quarter of a day, but they had to spend a portion of time before that simply waiting for the departure time to arrive.

On the way into the terminal, Ose scoffed. "I don't know why you insist on using human transportation. Warpers will get us there much faster."

"I like observing humans." Belial said. "And also, I enjoy plane rides. They give me lots of time to think."

"There's nothing enjoyable about them." Ose complained. "Stuck in a cabin, humans around us everywhere. I only deal with humans when I have to."

"It wouldn't do for the humans to uncover Satan's whereabouts. We're fortunate he remains elusive to this day." Belial patiently explained. "Using Warpers always emits a faint but traceable energy signal. I've long suspected the humans have a way of following our movements when we use Warpers, so I'd rather only use them in emergencies. That's why I took a plane ride to the western side of the states in the first place."

"Fine. Whatever." Ose grunted. "Must be nice, being able to bend your body in any direction. Even a uncomfortable airplane ride is no problem for the likes of you."

Belial raised an eyebrow. "You... you know I bought first-class tickets, right?"

"Oh." Ose said.

After a moment she scowled.

"Shut up!"

* * *

Hours later, the plane arrived at LaGuardia Airport on the east side of NYC, and the two women departed without any luggage, casually grabbing a taxi to ride back to the Legion Headquarters.

When they stepped inside the cab, the male cab driver's eyes nearly popped out of his head. He had never seen a pair of such stunningly beautiful women in all his years! They weren't just attractive, but beautiful in an almost ethereal way.

He turned around and opened his mouth to greet them, but then Ose snapped her eyes to meet his, and the look she gave him nearly drained the soul from his body.

"Legion Building. Drive fast. Don't talk, or I'll *fucking kill you*. I am *not* in the mood. Don't test me."

The man swallowed the words he was going to say. Her fiery temper excited him, but he also felt she absolutely would and could kill him without a second's thought, something he genuinely couldn't understand why he'd ever believe.

"Y-yes, ma'am." The cab driver mumbled, before sheepishly shifting the cab's gears and taking off.

Belial and Ose remained completely silent. They both crossed their arms and looked out the rear passenger windows nearest them, not opting to speak to one another in the presence of a human. The cab remained completely silent, save for the driver's watery swallowing sounds. He had never felt more awkward in his entire life.

Just who the hell are these babes? The man wondered. *What I wouldn't give for one night with them...*

The cab finally came to a stop after forty-five minutes of driving in medium traffic. In truth, if Ose had used her powers, she could have transmitted her body to Legion HQ within three seconds, but that could have drawn attention, and the ever-cautious Belial *insisted* on taking the slower, more proper channels.

Oh well, Ose thought. *It's not like our lives are getting any shorter. Immortals have all the time in the world.*

She was all too happy to step out of the cab, especially since the driver's body odor had assaulted her sensitive nostrils the entire way. Maybe later when Belial wasn't looking, Ose would hunt him in the dead of night and murder him just so he'd never be able to

think those awful lurid thoughts she *knew* he was thinking the entire drive. Human males were all such damned pigs!

After the cab drove away, Belial finally turned and spoke to her lesser peer.

"Be bold. Satan likes strong types. Male and female alike. He doesn't like wimpy or demure girls. Get on his good side, and he'll give you most of what you want."

Ose sneered. "He'll give me *everything* I demand, don't you worry about that."

Belial nodded in a *not bad* sort of way, puffing out her lower lip slightly. "Well alright then. Let's meet the Devil."

Ose had spoken to Satan a few times over the years, but as the First Emperor, it was never really in her prerogative to meet with him one-on-one. She had only ever exchanged a few words when traveling to see him alongside her mother. Lucifer was a powerful Demoness, and a longtime ally of his, if not an actual 'friend'. Ose, by contrast, was just some pretty white-haired demoness he only faintly recalled due to her mother. He knew she was the one demoness who was adept with human technology, but that simply didn't impress him since he thoroughly believed humans were a lesser species propped up by their Heroes and a few key technologies. They were otherwise weak, pathetic, and unimpressive.

Ose's eyes flashed with insight. She had conversed with Belial during the flight, carefully probing important bits of information regarding the First Emperor, and by now her plan had reached an 85% confidence threshold. There was room to make a terrible error, but she believed she could meet her goals, and maybe even surpass them, if she played her cards right.

Both women entered the lobby. A man at the entry desk perked up when he saw Belial.

"Miss Lily, so good to see you back. Shall I call ahead to let Mister Hercule know you've arrived?"

Belial smiled prettily at the man. "He already knows."

Indeed, Satan had sensed her unique demonic mana when her plane flew over the city, after she deliberately leaked a small portion of it out. This leak was so brief that it couldn't be used to ascertain her whereabouts, only her existence to those sensitive to such sensations.

Belial and Ose took the elevator. They arrived on the top floor, where the secondary secretary blinked in surprise before quickly standing up from Belial's desk.

"Lily! You're back. It's good to see you! I've made sure to keep Mister Hercule's arrangements in order during your work trip."

Belial smiled at her cute little coworker. Her succubus instincts flared up for a moment as she smelled some familiar pheromones on the women's high heels. It seemed Satan had a little fun while she was away.

"You can hold the fort down a while longer." Belial said without much interest. "I've brought a guest to meet the CEO."

She didn't bother introducing Ose to the two random human women. They didn't really matter, and Ose wouldn't have been interested. Plus, it was neither of the two lesser secretary's business anyway. They only existed to take care of Satan's needs when Belial left, *whatever* those needs might be.

Poor dears. They had no idea they were merely fragile mortal toys, meant to be discarded once Satan tired of them. Belial almost felt some pity for them, but that feeling disappeared when she remembered the thousands of other human women Satan had gone through over the millennia. He might have his own animal needs, but he almost didn't value human women for anything but their bodies.

There were rare exceptions, of course, namely when it came to female Heroes or other noteworthy figures, but those were few and far between.

Belial pushed open the door to the office. She found 'Mark Hercule' sitting on a chair, playing a fiddle softly, seemingly lost in thought. When the door opened, he blinked a few times to clear his mental haze, then smiled at Belial as the door closed. "Lily! Glad to see you back. And this is...?"

Satan didn't recognize the woman standing beside his 'head secretary', and he wasn't certain if she was human or demon. But after a moment, he noticed the red ring on her finger, which Ose made no attempt to disguise.

Ose remained silent for a moment. "Hmm."

She turned her head from left to right, causing Satan to slightly frown. The fact she hadn't introduced herself was... odd. He couldn't remember the last time this had happened...

Suddenly, Ose's body flickered. She abruptly disappeared from the spot and zipped over to one of Satan's displays, where his trophy collection from his Martial Arts World Championships stood.

Before Satan could react, she smashed her fist into the glass, grabbed one of the trophies, and threw it onto the ground, breaking it into a hundred pieces!

"Wh-what the fuck?!" Satan roared, his eyes igniting with rage. "You!! What the HELL do you think-"

"Quiet." Ose said, directing a glare toward him. Her body flickered again, and in an instant, she was bent over, reaching into the debris to grab a tiny object even Satan could barely see with his superior demonic vision.

Ose flickered over to him, holding the object between her fingers.

"First Emperor Satan. Your office is bugged. And not just a little bugged. A *lot* bugged."

Satan's fury shifted slightly. He was still clearly pissed about his broken trophy and was just about ready to throw his fiddle at this pompous bitch who dared wreak havoc in his office, but he held himself back.

"Bugged? The *fuck* you mean, 'bugged'?" Satan snapped. "Ain't no bug I've ever seen!"

"I don't mean a literal bug, you imbecile." Ose said, not even flinching in the face of his rage. "I'm talking about human reconnaissance technology. They are watching you, listening to you, peeping in on every private moment that happens in this office."

Suddenly, Ose's eyes flashed with white light. She abruptly spread out her arms and sent surges of electricity all over the place, arcing towards shelves, power outlets on the walls, even obliterating several of the lights in the room. Luckily, the early morning sun kept the office well-lit, not that it would have mattered. Demons had incredible vision, even during the blackest of nights.

The sounds of shattering glass, exploding furniture, and other violent noises immediately drew the attention of the two secretaries outside, but luckily before they could activate the silent alarm, Belial knocked on the door thrice to indicate nothing was amiss. They could only begrudgingly wait to find out what all the ruckus was about... later.

Satan's rage turned to confusion. His mouth gaped open, as if he could not believe the audacity of this bitch. By now he knew she was a demon, that much was obvious, but he could not fathom what bimbo would be so stupid as to wreck his office and light a fire under his ass. Did she not realize her life was in jeopardy?!

Ose's eyes stopped glowing. She looked around the destroyed office with a hint of satisfaction. "Alright. I destroyed all of them. We're safe... for now."

"Safe?!" Satan yelled. "Oh I wouldn't be so sure of your safety, you fucking bitch! What's the meaning of all this? Lilia?!"

He turned his head to look at his wife, but Belial was just as baffled. What the hell was Ose doing? What was she THINKING?! Wasn't she here to lower her head, speak words that would achieve certain goals, and obtain what she wanted? She had just made a horrid impression on the leader of demonkind! If she didn't have a good explanation, she might lose her life today! Lucifer certainly wouldn't make it in time to save her.

"Don't look at *her* you dolt." Ose retorted with a snarl. "I'm the one talking. Devils. What an imbecile. First Emperor my ass. You're outdated. You're feeding the humans all the information they could ever want. I may have even just saved your life, and you don't even know what I did."

At this point, Satan's rage had shifted from confusion to respect. He had to admit, it had been a long time since someone had the balls, or lack thereof, to speak to him in such a manner. And based on the aura this woman leaked, she wasn't even a Duke! She was only a Baron... but who was she?

He decided to ask. Instead of getting even madder, he became strangely calm. He assessed the woman with cold, ruthless eyes.

"Your name?"

"Ose, the Baron of Infiltration." She immediately replied. "Lucifer's adopted daughter."

Satan blinked. Yes, now that he thought about it...

"Lucy's little girl, huh? You think mommy's gonna protect you if I beat you to a bloody pulp? Or do you have some other assurance?"

Satan stood up, but his horns didn't even reach the top of her shoulders. Ose was much taller than him.

She didn't balk in the slightest at his threat. "So this is how you repay my gift? And after all the stories I'd heard of your wisdom and generosity. It seems those were nothing more than lies told to deceive the Grunts."

"Gift?" Satan asked, glancing around his destroyed office. "Little girl, I don't know what you're talkin' about, but killing a bunch of bugs don't impress me."

Ose resisted the urge to facepalm. It seemed he still didn't understand anything.

Slowly, deliberately, she held up the tiny black device in her fingers.

"Listen carefully, First Emperor. This is a 'bug'. Not a literal bug. A metaphorical one. It's human-based technology. This bug, specifically, is used to record audio within a wide band frequency. It can pick up any noise in this office within a certain distance, then transmit that noise to a location unknown."

She paused for half a breath.

"It's a human *spying* device. Like what Seers use to scry the future. Do you understand now?"

Satan scoffed, but he looked at the tiny flat disc in her grasp with a more careful gaze. "Nuh-uh. No way. You think I'm stupid? That tiny little thing? *That* can spy on me?"

"It can. And it did, until thirty seconds ago." Ose said, without batting an eye. "Let me guess. You think the humans don't know who you are. You think you're secure here, hidden away. You probably even think you've embedded yourself well into the human world. But you're wrong. They know who you are, and they've been *laughing* at you. You're like an old man who doesn't have any idea what tomfoolery his grandchildren are up to, even as they cart him off to a retirement home."

The more Ose spoke, the more doubtful Satan became. He started to remember more and more about this girl. He heard stories that she was 'good with human tech stuff' from a few other demons, but that didn't offer him any concrete value until this very moment. Now, Satan suddenly realized he was woefully underprepared for whatever the humans might be cooking up. He thought back to a lot of private conversations he'd had, conversations about secret missions he'd planned that later went awry. He had always thought it was suspicious that the humans got wind of those plans so easily... but *now*?

"Those... those bastards." Satan muttered, his tone much softer than before. "They've really been spying on me? You mean it?"

Ose's body flickered. She zipped around the office at a dizzying pace, leaving Satan's vision spinning. He was secretly shocked by her speed. Only a Baron, but already this incredible? She was a real talent! An absolute gem!

She appeared before the Devil a few moments later, opening her hands to let more than fifty tiny black plastic objects fall through her fingers and clatter to the ground.

"Take a look for yourself." Ose said.

Satan's Vectors snapped downward. They passed through the floor, scooped up the plastic doodads, and became corporeal as they brought them up to his eye-level. Satan carefully picked one up and looked at it, but to him, it just looked like a tiny marble.

"...You're *sure*?" Satan asked doubtfully.

Ose nodded. Her expression turned grave. She picked out one item at random, then carefully opened it up with her fingernails. Just like that, its tiny internal circuits became visible.

"This is a camera. It can record video, albeit at a low quality, and transmit it to a remote location. If I had to wager a guess, I'd bet someone close to you planted it when you weren't in the office."

She paused, then cocked her head.

"Do you have any maid services? Cleaners?"

Satan shrugged. "Sure, a few of 'em."

"They're the most likely suspects. Anytime you've ever left someone alone in the office, they could have planted a bug too. You should assume this entire building is bugged to keep an eye on you wherever you go."

Satan finally sobered up. He raised his head to meet the woman's eyes, a woman who exposed something he'd never have guessed due to his ignorance regarding human technology.

"Ose, huh? Lucy's little girl?"

Ose touched her red ring, revealing her true form. She bowed her head slightly to show respect, but not deference. "That's right, First Emperor. And I've come today to speak to you about a very important matter."

Satan nodded. He no longer looked at her as if she were a weakling Baron, but a potential powerhouse! The conspiracy she had just unraveled made her equally as important in his eyes as some of the lesser Emperors he didn't think too highly of, and perhaps even Emperors better than them.

"You have my full and undivided attention." Satan said, crossing his arms.

Some time later, Ose finished explaining the events that occurred at the Illuminati Haven. Belial had sat down in a chair and discarded her human disguise, only nodding and occasionally chiming in to validate Ose's words, but otherwise keeping silent. She found herself continually impressed by Ose's clear-headed manner of speech, as well as her ability to describe situations with great eloquence.

"Two Trueborn Heroes." Satan said, after hearing Ose's full explanation. "One of them has super fast reaction speeds, planetary-teleportation capabilities, pinpoint-perfect aim, and a gun that shoots bullets capable of ripping right through Lilia's flesh. The other is a bit bratty, but his Dream Eating power means he'll become a fearsome foe in the future. That about it?"

"They also are being empowered, possibly by an Ancestor Hero." Ose added. "Jason's body was far too durable. I was unable to cause severe damage to him with my current strength. I lost my chance to assassinate him on the spot."

"That's a shame." Satan said, as he looked away and stroked his goatee. "That's a *damn* shame."

He turned and walked away, heading to the window while wading around destroyed pieces of furniture strewn about his office. By now, he had completely lost interest in his destroyed trophies and other knick-knacks. Today's news was far too important for him to ignore.

"See, here's the thing, toots." Satan began. "I ain't afraid of humans killing me. It ain't possible. It simply ain't. You don't know me well, but trust me. If Arthur couldn't do it, *nobody* could. Not even a pair of powerful Trueborn like Cat Mask and the Archseer."

Ose remained silent, and Satan continued to speak.

"These humans ain't a threat to *me*, specifically, but they are a threat to other demons. And that's where the problems begin. I can't ignore this. Can't keep quiet."

Satan looked at her with deep meaning.

"You don't gotta say it. I know what you want. You want to become an Emperor."

Ose's body twitched. She was surprised to hear him state it so simply, but considering the shocks she had given him, this was nothing by comparison. She simply nodded.

"You will give me the power of an Emperor." Ose said, not bothering to phrase it as a question. "Demonkind's future depends on it. The Archseer listed me and my brother as high-value targets. I don't know why Gressil is so important to kill, but I can certainly understand why I am. My knowledge of humanity's technology means I can be a balance-tipping point in the upcoming war. You would be a fool to ignore this."

Satan looked at Ose. He chuckled softly under his breath.

Seriously, how long had it been since someone dared to speak to him in such a manner, let alone a weak little Baron girl? In his eyes, she was barely out of diapers. Not even close to a millennia old, yet she spoke to this 10,000 year old monster as if she were his equal, or even his superior!

But Satan didn't hold it against her. She had the ability to do so. As the First Emperor of Demonkind, the only trait he valued in subordinates was competence. She had demonstrated her capabilities by rooting out the human 'bugs' and showed him why so many missions had failed in recent years. He would have remained completely oblivious to this threat for devils knew how long, perhaps until it led to the death of his entire species!

She has her mother's ego. Satan thought to himself. *But unlike Lucy, Ose is actually smart*.

He smiled.

I like her.

"Alright, toots. I'll play it straight with you." Satan said, turning to fully face her. "Usually I like to play games, test people before I make them a Duke, and especially before I make 'em an Emperor. But not this time."

His smile disappeared.

"The stakes are too high. I'll personally escort you to Hellga. She keeps the soul pills. We might *barely* have enough to boost you. Unfortunately, aquiring enough human souls

to uplift an Emperor ain't easy these days. But who knows... maybe it'll become a lot easier in due time."

Satan frowned. He suddenly remembered he'd spoken about his secret plans regarding the *Labyrinth* project in this very room on more than one occasion. The humans were likely to know about it.

"Damn. Motherfucking humans." Satan hissed, before lightly pounding the side of his fist on his mahogany desk. He looked at Ose with a flash of insight. "Say, any shot you'd be able to find out who planted these buggers?"

Ose shrugged helplessly. "I am only a Baron. My powers are not at that level yet. Perhaps, once I am an Emperor, I will obtain such a capability."

Satan's smile returned in full force. *Ah, finally, a lie. Almost could've fooled me with that line before. Hehe, but it's okay. I don't mind a subordinate with ambition, especially if she's got brains.*

He gestured at Ose's ring. "C'mon, let's get a move on. Lilia, you stay here and make sure nobody enters. I don't want any of those damn buggers gettin' back in here again."

Belial waved her hand. "Sure. I'm pretty tired from the flight anyway. I'll take a nap until you return."

"Hehe, love ya, toots." Satan said, as Ose reverted to her human form and the two of them walked out of the office together.

The timeline of the Energy Wars had already begun to change in a drastic way...

Part 638: Compromised

January 24th, 2021. Noon, Northern California.

While Ose and Satan went on their fateful journey together, somewhere across the USA, on the far opposite side, there sat a male demon on a hill. The midday wind slowly swished around him, its wintery chill doing nothing to affect his body's temperature.

The demon sat at the very top of the hill with a calm, serene expression on his face. He looked out at the distant coastline, the small human settlement known as Crescent City, and he contemplated a great many things.

The meaning of life. His purpose. His feelings about the world.

His name was Gressil. He was a mere Baron of the Third Hell of Blood, but he had been a Baron for many many hundreds of years. He had evolved to his current rank through the contributions of helping other demons, a long time ago. He had been respected once. He had even been the leader of a small enclave within the Hell of Calamity... before King Arthur's men ran roughshod through it, swept up his enclave and killed many of its members.

These days, he was nothing. He was nobody. No longer noteworthy. No longer respected.

Gressil stared out across the midday horizon. He looked up at the clouds and sighed softly.

Only a few days earlier, Ose had practically dragged him along on a mission to assault the Illuminati Haven. He wanted to refuse, but he wasn't any good at telling his cute little sister 'no'. He didn't exactly dote on her, but whenever he looked into her eyes, a flash of pain ran through his heart.

Ose was only a child when her other older brothers had died. She was young... far too young. But Gressil was older. He remembered their faces and names. He remembered the good times he spent with them. He remembered their screams of agony as Arthur's minions tortured and maimed them.

But those events happened a long, long time ago. These days, Gressil didn't think about them much. He had other matters on his mind.

Gressil motioned with his hands. He summoned a small cloud of illusory butterflies, allowing them to gently fly around him in circles. He didn't know why he loved doing this so much. He only knew it calmed him down and made him feel more at peace.

Butterflies were so simple, so innocent. They were creatures that operated purely on instinct. The animal kingdom could be cruel and indifferent at times, but there were plenty of animals that lived tranquil lives. Nature might be eat-or-be-eaten, but it wasn't always kill-or-be-killed.

"Hey! Hey Gres! You up here again??"

Gressil's tranquil mood dissipated. He blinked and looked to the north, where he saw a female demoness climbing the mountain. She was attractive, with long brown hair and two perky pigtails. She wore a prim and proper outfit, but she had a good figure too. Not like him, who was tall, lanky, and otherwise ordinary looking. Gressil sometimes looked in a mirror and found his reflection depressing, but he didn't really feel like fixing it either. He simply was who he was. He had no desire to change himself.

"Hello, Abby." Gressil said softly, his words practically whispered on the wind. Luckily, Abby's sharp ears picked up on them.

"There you are! I should have known you'd come hide up here, like usual." Abby said, as she sprinted the rest of the way up the hill. She breathed only a little heavier than usual, but it was evident she'd been running around for quite a while without rest. "Have you seen Ose? I keep asking but nobody will tell me where to find her!"

Gressil slowly blinked his eyes. He returned his gaze out to the horizon.

"She left with Belial. I don't know why."

"What?! She left without ME?!" Abby screeched. "Oh, this is so unfair! I told her to tell me when she was taking a trip! I wouldn't want her to be lonely without me!"

Gressil didn't bother explaining that Ose actually hated interacting with Abby. Abby was completely oblivious about her one-sided love, and she never believed him when he explained in the past anyway.

So, he simply remained silent.

Abby moaned and groaned for a few seconds longer before frowning and looking at him.

"Hm? Gres? You okay?"

Gressil softly sighed. "I am fine."

She stared at him for a few moments, then walked over and sat down beside him.

"You always say that. But you're not fine. Something's on your mind."

Gressil didn't argue the point. She was right. He *was* feeling more down than usual... and that was saying a lot.

Gressil lowered his eyes. With his acute demonic vision, he stared at a bee crawling on a nearby dandelion flower. He watched it as it went about its business, then took to the air and flew away. Bees were becoming a rarer sight over the years. A symptom of humanity's destruction of their environment.

"Why do we kill humans?" Gressil asked.

Abby blinked. She turned her head to look at the side profile of his face, then returned her gaze back out to the horizon.

"That's a weird question, Gres. We're demons. It's what we do."

"But why?" Gressil asked.

Abby fell silent. She chewed on his question in her head.

"Well. Humans have hurt a lot of demons. You and I know this better than others. We were both there when King Arthur tore up our enclave. It's only natural we have to fight for our survival."

Gressil slowly blinked. "That is not an accurate summary of past events. Demons attacked the humans. Arthur's men were retaliating against us."

"Sure, but the humans attacked us before then. Remember the Culling Hunts?" Abby asked.

"Right. And before that, we attacked them, and before that, they attacked us..." Gressil said.

He paused for a few moments, then closed his eyes and sighed.

"Isn't it all so... pointless? A cycle of violence. Unending. All so... Chaotic. Lacking in Order. Murder for murder's sake."

Abby didn't respond immediately. She again thought about his greater point.

"You're not wrong, Gres. But... what's the alternative? We could try and figure out which species started the war, but it wouldn't matter. The demons and humans would still

have all the recent atrocities to point at. Everyone would point fingers. Nothing would change."

Gressil rested his hands on his lap. He opened his eyes and gazed upon a distant bird in a tree.

"I don't know. A temporary ceasefire. Something that would make us pause our hostilities toward each other. Something that would allow a generation of humans to grow old, pass away, and bring forth new ones who didn't remember the old pains caused and suffered by their elders. Maybe then, we could start to heal our old wounds."

Abby nibbled on her lower lip. "Where's all this coming from? Don't tell me that fight with the Illuminati affected you this much?"

"I won't lie. It did." Gressil muttered. "We overpowered the humans. We slaughtered them with great ease. Dozens, perhaps even hundreds dead. Reduced to meat paste. By contrast, we suffered no losses. Mother ate a bullet and passed out... that was the worst extent of our injuries. And the cause of all this suffering? A simple desire to root out the truth about the two Trueborn Heroes."

Gressil paused for a moment.

"Sentients... are all so greedy, Abby. They are all ruled by Desire. They seek their own enrichment. They think selfish thoughts, only working to uplift themselves. When causing pain to others, rarely do they imagine what it would feel like if such pain were inflicted on them instead."

Abby quietly looked at Gressil's face again. He looked so hurt by what he had seen. So damaged. But the pain he felt did not only come from those humans...

"Are you always this... ponderous?" Abby asked, her voice low. "I didn't know you had such... broad thoughts. You and Ose are really similar."

"I don't know." Gressil muttered. "Those Heroes said they wanted me and my sister dead. But why? What have we ever done to them? Is there not some way we could make amends? Stop the eternal cycle of pain and suffering? Why must bloodshed be the only language we speak?"

After a moment's hesitation, Abby reached over and looped her arm around Gressil's. She leaned her head against his shoulder and sighed.

"Jeez, Gres. You're really bringing down my mood here. All this heavy talk... it makes me wish Lucifer would be nicer to you."

Gressil turned his head slightly. He looked at the top of Abby's hair, felt the soft skin of her arm twined with his.

"That is something I wish too. All the time." Gressil muttered.

The two of them remained sitting there for many many hours together, pondering about the brutality of the world together.

January 24th, 2021. Noon, New York State.

Somewhere in the suburbs, far from the hustle and bustle of New York City, a pair of false humans slowly walked into the countryside. They kept watch for pursuers, but it didn't seem anyone had followed them to their destination.

"This is the place." Satan the Devil growled. He gestured vaguely toward a spot somewhere in the forest, though Ose didn't see anything special about it. "Can't get in unless you know how to do all the ritual bullshit. Or unless you're me. Heh."

Satan made an exaggerated snapping motion with his fingers. Instantly, a magical contract appeared in his grasp. Then, he touched a few words on the densely-written page, and they began to glow with unholy red demonic light.

The forest lit up with an ominous, bloody energy. Distant screams seemed to waft into Ose's ears. Even as a mentally resilient demoness, she felt deeply discomforted by the raw negative energy in the air.

"You wouldn't believe how many human souls we use to make places like this." Satan said, as glowing pentagrams began to appear on the ground, etched into the nearby trees, and even onto the bodies of birds in the branches above. "You wouldn't believe it."

A *whoomph* of air erupted from within the forest's depths. It struck the two demons, but Ose dug her heels into the ground and stiffened her posture so she wouldn't fall over. Satan, by comparison, didn't even flinch.

After that, a crystal clear oval-shaped portal slowly materialized in the air. Satan remained standing in place for over five minutes as it expanded, then grew to a size big

enough for both of them to walk through. Eventually, it changed appearance to reveal some sort of underground chamber lit by glowing demonstones.

"After you, toots." Satan said, gesturing toward it.

Ose nodded. She strode forward and boldly walked inside without any fear. If this was all some ploy to kill her, that would be profoundly stupid on Satan's part, and if some ancient horror wanted to sneak attack her once she entered, she doubted it could contend with the First Emperor of demonkind.

She entered the underground chamber and found a series of human cultists inside, their faces masked, all of them standing with their palms clasped together against their waists. They stood in a line, saying nothing, facing the portal's entrance as Ose and Satan entered. She stood atop a platform elevated maybe ten feet off the ground, and at the bottom of the stairs leading downward, even more human cultists stood at attention, awaiting Satan's arrival.

The First Emperor smiled as the portal closed behind him.

"Good work, ladies, gents. You can all die now."

The moment the words left his mouth, all the humans stiffened, slumped forward, and fell down, dead. They collapsed into their shadows, ending up a line of corpses on the ground. Ose looked around the room at the thirty or so dead bodies, then promptly ignored them. They were only human. Their lives held no value in her eyes.

"Does this happen every time you open a portal?" She asked, as she and Satan made their way down the stairs.

"Huh? Yeah, but it's no big deal. The big city has lots of vagrants, homeless people, poor shlubs. It's easy to make a few go missing once in a while. We've still got a few hundred more in the back wing, waiting to be used when we leave later."

Ose nodded slowly. "And none of them are compromised?"

"Compromised?" Satan scoffed. "And how would that be the case?"

She looked at him out of the corner of her eye, then shook her head. "Nothing. Seems you have everything under control."

The two walked deeper into the chamber. Before long, a pair of handsome Demon Lords strode out and bowed at the waist. "Emperor Satan."

"I'm here to see Hellga." Satan said. "I'm giving a promotion to Baron Ose."

The two males straightened their postures. They appraised Ose, then nodded.

"Of course." One of them said. "This way."

They led Satan and Ose deeper into the tunnels, where they passed various chambers with human slaves pounding hammers against anvils, forging items under the beady-eyed watch of slave-drivers behind them. Sometimes they passed vast underground chambers where humans were mining demonstone slowly, painfully, with whips cracking at their backs if they slowed down.

"This is just one of many underground complexes for building demonkind's armies." Satan explained. "We've got a bunch of 'em all over the place. This one's a bit more special than the others, since it's the one I visit most often, but it's not too far beyond what you'd expect from other facilities."

"Demonstone grows back after you've mined it." Ose commented idly. "It's not only a renewable resource, but plentiful and easy to find, so long as many demons congregate in one area."

"We've got mountains of the stuff just lying around. Honestly, it's a bit of a nuisance." Satan replied. "Keeps growing forever if we don't mine it. Once we dig it out of the ground, it goes inert. I just wish we had something useful we could use it all for."

Ose blinked. "Aren't you crafting armor with it? Weapons?"

"Nah. Mostly just furniture." Satan said. "Don't get me wrong, demonstone is extremely tough, but most demons would rather use their magical abilities to fight humans. It's not very prestigious to go out there in armor like the humans do. It's beneath us."

Ose frowned deeply. She knew demonstone was quite abundant, but she had no idea it was to the extent Satan had said. Her mind began to revolve as she started thinking about a great many things...

Satan stopped before a giant door at the end of the hallway. There were all sorts of demonic symbols etched into it, engravings of torturous ceremonies, among other things. He ignored those, bit his thumb, and sent a drop of blood toward the door. The drop exploded into a faint mist, then the door activated and slid into the wall, revealing the Blood Pits within.

This was one of demonkind's healing havens; a place where badly injured and maimed demons could come to heal their bodies and revive themselves from all but the most dire of wounds. The blood was taken from humans, empowered through magical processes Ose had no knowledge of, and was part of an ancient tradition that ensured demons could stay alive and outlive their weak, pathetic human enemies for millennia upon millennia.

The two nameless Demon Lords stood at attention outside, allowing Satan and Ose to enter the Blood Pits by themselves.

A gorgeous young demon girl with curly brown hair bounded over to them and smiled cutely. "Satan! Hello, darling! Why have you come to see me?"

Satan grinned. "Hellga! Just the gal I was lookin' for. This here is Lucy's little girl, Ose. She's a Baron, but due to a recent contribution, I'm gonna need some souls for her. I'm promoting her to Emperor."

Some of the demons laying in the pools of blood jolted awake in surprise. It had been over a hundred years since the last time a demon was evolved to the rank of Emperor, and they certainly didn't expect to be in the room when it was announced.

"Ose? Oh, how nice to meet you!" Hellga chirped, puffing out her bountiful chest. "Wow, you're so beautiful too! I've heard you're like a genius with the human gadgets, yeah?"

Ose nodded. "That seems to be the case."

"Brains and beauty! Some girls get all the good stuff..." Hellga pouted. "Well, you're in luck. I have a surplus on pills. Some human genocides have been playing out in the Middle East, so we've been reaping quite a few from our passive sources. Come on, this way!"

She led Satan and Ose to the back of the blood pits, then entered a secret chamber by passing through an illusory wall. When Ose followed after, the distant sounds of screaming she had heard at the entrance became far louder, and much more violent! Wailing howls of agony from captured human souls sniffled and sobbed as they waiting within a purgatory, unable to die, unable to revive as angels in Heaven.

"Over the years," Satan explained, "we've found all sorts of vulnerabilities in the Lazarus Tower. We can nick souls from the angels if the humans don't pray enough, or if I

can get 'em to sign one of my contracts. It's not much, but we manage to pick up maybe ten or twenty million a year."

Ose looked at him. "That's enough to raise more than a dozen Emperors every year."

"Bad idea. Too many chiefs, not enough Indians." Satan said while waving his hand flippantly. "Trust me, even if we only uplifted one Emperor a year, it'd create chaos. We tried that for a while and things got way out of hand. That's why we had to make the Seven Hells. Too many power struggles otherwise. The existing Emperors agreed only to uplift a new one after long periods of stability, or if one of the old ones died."

He looked back at her. "You're a special case. Don't make me regret doin' this."

Ose bared a toothy grin at him. "Oh, don't you worry, *I won't*. This is the best decision you could have made this century."

Satan looked at her solemnly. "I hope so."

Then, he turned to Hellga, who had already procured a handful of pitch-black soul pills she condensed on the spot. The number of errant souls in the room plummeted drastically as they were sealed inside the pills.

"We only have a few thousand souls left over." Hellga said, directing an appraising eye toward Ose. "You've consumed 11,201 souls so far. Inside these pills, there is a total of 988,799 souls. Just enough to get you to one million and past the barrier of Emperor."

"How do you know the number of souls I've consumed?" Ose asked. "I've been a Baron for several hundred years now."

"Oh, that? I can just tell by looking. It's an acquired ability!" Hellga said happily. "Now, let's not wait any longer. Emperor Satan does not uplift other Emperors often, so I'm looking forward to seeing what sort of powerhouse you will become!"

"Hold on just a second." Satan said, stepping between her and Ose. Ose frowned.

"What now?" Ose asked.

Satan didn't use words to reply. He simply waved his hand and summoned a magical contract.

"Sign this first. With blood."

Ose frowned. She knew there had to be a catch. She snatched the contract, then scanned it with her eyes. Other demons might be confused when reading the terms, but

she had multiple degrees in law from human colleges. She saw right through a hundred different traps.

"Hahahaha. A slave contract? How clever, Satan. I'm not signing this."

Satan shrugged. "Saw through me that easy, huh? Well, I'd have been disappointed if you didn't. Actually, I'd rather you just sign the same one your mom did. It's not as restrictive-"

"I'm not signing *any* of your contracts." Ose interrupted, her eyes flashing with sinister light. "Not one clause, not one binding vow... *nothing*."

Satan blinked. He looked at her in surprise, but then his eyes hardened.

"Tough girl, huh? That ain't how this works, toots. You don't become an Emperor without my say-so. No signature, no Emperor rank. It's that simple."

Ose didn't back down. She loomed over him and sneered.

"Oh, Satan, *darling*. You don't get to threaten me. You need me to become an Emperor more than even I do. You simply haven't realized it yet."

Satan scoffed. "The fuck are you talkin' about? You tryin'a play games with me?"

"Not games. The cold, hard truth." Ose bit back. "You still don't get it. You're compromised, Satan. You're not as powerful and all-seeing as you think. The humans have been watching you for at least a decade, if not longer. They've bugged your offices, tagged your minions, and have likely infiltrated deep into our bases. If I sign one of your contract, I become another one of your 'assets'. A pawn they can use you to manipulate."

"The contract I had your mom sign ain't that bad. Don't be a baby." Satan retorted. "I'll be able to know where you are at all times. That's it. No restrictions, nothing else."

"And if I die?" Ose asked.

"If you die, I get your soul." Satan said. "What, you want it to go to the Lazarus Tower instead? With the angels?"

"My soul is mine." Ose said, leaning back and crossing her arms. She looked down at him with an even more derisive sneer than before. "I have *plans* for my soul, should I die someday. Hopefully, that will never happen. But if it does, I'll be prepared. In any case, I'm not signing a contract binding me to humanity's greatest mole. You're a liability."

Satan's glare turned ugly. "I've killed bitches for saying less than that."

"Yeah? And were those 'bitches' at the top of the Trueborn's kill-list when they were only a mere Baron?" Ose probed. "You *need* me. Right now, demonkind is in the most precarious position it's ever been. This is the time to elevate an Emperor not bound by the old paradigms."

She shrugged and looked away. "Or don't. Flip that coin. *See what happens*."

Satan looked doubtful. He looked at the ground and rubbed his chin for a minute or two while Hellga stood silently behind him, the soul pills held tightly in her grasp.

Eventually, he nodded.

"So it's like that, huh? You think I'm compromised, just because of some buggers?"

"*And* the 'slaves' outside." Ose snapped back. "You idiot! You imbecile! This place isn't hidden at all! The humans have already planted moles in your midst! I sensed technological devices hidden inside their bodies. They have beacons that can guide the humans here at any point! You haven't even noticed because you and the other demons are too STUPID to notice! Willfully ignorant, blindly denying change that could empower our species. You are a relic of an older time, and an anchor holding us back from the greatness we could achieve."

The more Ose spoke, the more she began looking into the distance, as if peering at a future only she could see.

"Here's the new deal, Satan. You will make me an Emperor without any conditions. In return, I will use my powers to elevate demons FAR beyond anything you could imagine. If you are not willing to trust my judgment, then let's not speak of the matter anymore. Let the humans kill me, and you can pray you have what it takes to hold them back."

Ose fell silent. She no longer bother to argue her case, leaving Satan with a bit of a conundrum. On the one hand, she had disrespected him several times and called into question his leadership skills. On the other hand, her pointed criticisms were factually correct, and aside from Hellga, there weren't any other demons present in the secret chamber...

Satan frowned. He looked up at Ose, and she looked back down at him.

What a domineering woman.

She had the makings of a truly impressive Emperor...

"Alright." Satan finally said. "We'll do it your way. Hellga. Give her the pills. And erase your memories of the entire conversation up to now."

Hellga blinked. Her eyes dulled. Satan's contract swallowed her mind, and her memories disappeared. She looked at Ose blankly, then held out her palm with the soul pills in it.

Ose took the pills gratefully. She looked at them with eager eyes.

"You've made the right decision, Emperor Satan." She said, glancing at him for a split second before returning her gaze to those delectable pills.

Satan opened his mouth to say something, but then he paused and shrugged. "Don't eat 'em too fast. It'll hurt like hell if ya do."

Ose grinned as she gazed at the treasure in her hands. "I am no stranger to *agony*."

Without another word, she grabbed the pills and threw them in her mouth. Ten marble-sized orbs flew down her throat, and she swallowed them with great gusto.

Instantly, they began dissolving. Souls tried to escape her body, only for her raw demonic power to greedily latch onto those poor, pathetic dead humans and melt them into raw soul energy that streamed into Ose's internal organs.

"ORAAAA!!!" Ose roared, as her aura began to surge.

Lightning exploded from her body. It slammed into the walls, pounded the door, and shook the entire underground complex. Luckily, Hellga had already smoothly taken refuge behind Satan, who easily protected her from the explosive power outbursts erupting from Ose's body.

As the catacombs rumbled, the demons in the Blood Pits sat up a little straighter, looking at the secret hall with fire in their eyes.

A new Emperor... had been elevated!

Part 639: Overpowering Ose

January 24th, 2021. Noon, Somewhere Underground...

Ose couldn't help herself. She burst into maniacal laughter as waves of demonic energy continuously condensed within her body, empowering her physical strength, enhancing the speed of her mind, and uplifting the magical power inherent to her physiology. She screamed with laughter for more than a minute, only for that laughter to abruptly freeze as waves of pain slammed into her brain. She staggered and leaned against the wall while lightning started sporadically firing out of her joints and arcing to the nearest metallic surfaces.

However, her pride was too strong. She refused to let herself look weak in front of the Devil himself. In an instant, she devised a counter. She deactivated all the electrical impulses in her brain that transmitted pain, allowing her to completely ignore the ripping and tearing of neurons and muscle fibers all throughout her vessel. After only a second or two of showing her pain, she stood up again, reverting to her previous smug appearance.

"At l-last!" Ose choked, her jaw still involuntarily clenching once in a while. "The rank of Emperor... is mine!"

Satan looked at her and smiled. "Not bad, toots. I'm actually a little impressed. Seems you were able to power through the pain."

Ose's teeth clenched together. She might have disabled her feelings of pain, but she couldn't ignore the sensation of nausea boiling within her stomach. She suppressed her trembling body and met Satan's gaze as evenly as she could.

"Today... marks... a turning point for demonkind's future." Ose said haltingly. "I can see it now. I can see a bright future awaiting us, once we take care of those two Trueborn Heroes. But we cannot delay. Every minute we don't kill them is a minute we lose in this new war."

Slowly, Ose's body adapted to its new status. The waves of pain and nausea slowed down, then eventually stopped. Just ten minutes after recklessly eating all the soul pills at once, Ose reached her final form.

Sensing that her apotheosis was complete, she directed a cold glare at Satan.

"First Emperor. You made a mistake allowing me to ascend without any *assurances*."

Before Satan could respond, Ose's leg snapped at his head. She kicked Satan with all her strength, sending him smashing through the secret chamber's doorway!

Satan hurtled through the air, flew above the blood pits, and splattered into a horrific bloody mess against the far wall, startling all the demons inside the Blood Pits. Many of them were badly injured. They were recuperating due to recent fights they'd been involved in, be it fights against human soldiers, angels, or even their fellow demons. They couldn't flee the Blood Pits even if they wanted! But demons were usually battle maniacs. Seeing Satan sent flying, they quickly started roaring for a good fight as they turned their attention to the new Emperor who dared to defy him.

Ose stepped out, her uplifted aura blazing with a righteous fury. A maniacal grin spread across her face.

"HEH HEH HEH." Ose gurgled in her throat. "Stupid bastard. Can you idiots believe he uplifted me without putting a single check on my power? HAHAHA. Men are all so stupid."

Satan's bloodied remains slid down the wall and landed on the floor with a wet *plop*. In her head, Ose counted down the seconds, knowing Satan would revive within one minute.

"Satan thinks he can control demonkind. Everyone is afraid of him." Ose boldly declared. "But the truth is, he's just an endlessly reviving bully. We all know he isn't truly unkillable. He has millions of souls inside him. Each time he dies, one of those souls gets *snuffed out*."

Satan's remains suddenly agitated on the ground. A hellish aura burst outward as he began rapidly reassembling himself.

Before he could fully finish, Ose flickered over to him, raised her leg straight above her head, then slammed it down in a brutal axe-kick.

BOOOM!!!!

The explosion from her kick atomized his remains and sprayed Satan's entrails in every direction, coating the entire wall in his blood and viscera. The shockwave that came afterward killed three Demon Grunts nearby, breaking all the bones in their bodies. Several others not much further away suffered terrible ruptures and tearing to their

internal organs, leaving them comatose and on the verge of death. Even more were left deafened, the explosion bursting their eardrums and leaving them reeling on the ground.

"So the math is quite simple." Ose declared, more to herself than to the remaining lower demons still capable of listening. "If he has a million souls stuffed in his piggish body, then I'll kill him a million times. And if he has TEN million souls, then I'll kill him ten million times! Eventually, he'll run out, and he'll stop reviving. See? It's tedious work, but it will eventually pay off!"

After sixty seconds, Satan started to revive again, but Ose launched her fist at his reanimating remains, blasting them apart with a thunder-punch.

"Once Satan is gone, that will be it! No more First Emperor. The demons will be free of a tyrant, and a new First Emperor will take over! Quite a good deal, isn't it?! We'll be able to put someone intelligent on the throne. Someone beautiful, someone with an actual BRAIN who can win this war in a metaphorical week!"

Ose glanced at Satan's remains, frowning when he started to revive at fifty-nine seconds and some change. It was probably just an anomaly though, and she killed him again.

"It's going to take me a while to kill him truly dead, but I'm sure you'll all be ecstatic once I do!" Ose declared. "I have plans for demonkind's future. BIG plans! I couldn't act on them before, but I can now! Soon, everything will be mine for the taking! If any other Emperors dare to get in my way, I'll just kill them too!"

Satan revived once again, but this time his revival only needed fifty-nine and a quarter seconds. Ose frowned when she killed him once more, and she wondered if the revival speed was merely a minor discrepancy. She killed him again, and again, while each time, his revival speed very slightly increased to be faster than the previous times.

Oh? Ose thought. *So it's like that. The more I kill him, the faster his body returns. Well, good! That means I'll be able to tear through his millions of souls far faster than I planned! Having to wait tens of years to fully finish him off would have been such a bore!*

Ose killed him ten times. A hundred times!

Her fists and legs were covered in the melted splatters of Satan's bones, teeth, eyeballs, and many other bodily extremities. His revival speed had already increased to the point

where he needed less than half a minute to return, but his remains were agitating even faster than that.

Ose breathed evenly. This wasn't just about killing Satan, but assessing her own uplifted status. She had already come to the shocking conclusion that while before, she could think over 100 times faster than any other demon, but now that speed was nearly 100,000 times faster!

It was unbelievable. During this simple slaughter of the First Emperor, in the half and full-minutes between Satan's revivals, Ose had already mentally completed a few of her simplest inventions, mapping out how those pieces of technology would need to be rewired, as well as how their designs should look. She was all set to complete a small portion of her future plans, and all she had been doing was casually thinking about a few dozen enhanced weapons and armor between sessions of kicking Satan's ass.

Soon, Ose thought, *my plan to build a demonic paradise will be able to be launched. I'll still need to find a world secreted away where the angels and Titans won't be able to find us, as well as the others... but once I do, I'll be able to build a new future for our people. Everyone will have no choice but to worship my greatness!*

The demoness's ego soared. In her head, she imagined herself as a phoenix rising to the heavens, its natural power and glory awing all who looked upon her.

It was pitiful that no other Sentients could match her brilliance or beauty!

Her fists and legs started moving faster and faster. She blasted Satan's regrowing body out of the Blood Pits into the central corridor, allowing the demons still alive inside the Blood Pits to breathe a little easier. Now they might actually survive the day, though they weren't sure how much longer it would take for her to finish killing all of Satan's souls, or if she even *could*.

She continued murdering the First Emperor. His revival time went from thirty seconds to twenty, then to fifteen, ten... even five!

Satan started reviving so quickly that the moment she destroyed his reanimating corpse, the splattered blood and gore would already be twitching and convulsing before it hit the far wall. She'd have to run over and destroy it again, and then again!

Still, Ose remained optimistic. She wasn't winded at all, and she estimated she could keep this up even if he started reviving the instant she punched him. A Demon Emperor's

endurance was tens of thousands of times greater than any human, so she knew she wasn't far off the mark.

Suddenly, Ose punched at Satan's splattered blood and bones, but in the time it took her fist to snap out, an arm made of bone and bloody muscles erupted from the wall, reached out, and grabbed her wrist.

"Huh?!" Ose yelped.

She tried to yank her arm out of the skeletal hand's grasp, but she was shocked to find that its grip was harder than demonstone! She couldn't believe how powerful it felt! Her own strength was nothing by comparison.

An instant later, the arm regrew its muscle, tendons, and skin. The rest of Satan's body followed, and he reappeared with an ugly grimace on his face.

"So that's how it's gonna be, eh, toots?"

The First Emperor was completely naked. He had a fat beer belly, but he also had extremely toned muscles on his arms and legs. He gripped Ose's wrist so tightly that her joints started to hurt.

"What the hell?" Ose said, his mind in a small bit of disarray. "You're not this strong!"

"Correct." Satan said, his grimace turning to a grin. "Usually, I *ain't*."

He thrust his palm at Ose's chest and released her arm the instant he made contact.

THUMP!!

All the wind was driven from Ose's body as that single palm strike crashed into her rib-cage and sent her flying! Ose pounded against the wall just a few feet behind her. Her arms and legs splayed out helplessly, leaving a deep indentation in the wall and rumbling the local continental plates.

"Ya know." Satan said. "It *hurts* dyin' that many times. It really pisses me off."

Ose coughed. She slumped from the wall and fell to the ground, momentary paralyzed from pain. She shakily raised her head to see that Satan had conjured himself a brand new suit to cover his body.

"Nuh... not... possible..." Ose coughed, blood spewing from her ruptured lungs. "You... not... that strong... kuh!"

"For a broad who thinks she's the smartest person on Earth, you sure are as dumb as a bag of bricks." Satan said, looming over her. "You think my only power is to revive? If that were it, I wouldn't have risen to become the First Emperor. I've got a *little more than that* goin' on, doll."

Ose suddenly lashed out. She launched a powerful thunder-punch at Satan's face, roaring with rage at the fact he had somehow tricked her.

But her fist didn't land. Satan casually slapped with his palm, redirected the punch, and battered her arm against the wall.

"Aaargh!" Ose cried. Her right arm broke in multiple places, rendering it completely useless!

"I don't *need* the contracts, Ose." Satan said, his eyes dim with barely-contained anger. "I use 'em cause they make life easier. Because if all the other demons know I'm always watching, they won't try to pull any shit that would piss me off. But those contracts ain't a necessity. I can do just fine without 'em."

He grabbed Ose by the hair, and his Vectors lashed out, grabbed each of her limbs, and pinned her to the ground.

Satan forced her head up. He snarled in her ear.

"Listen carefully, ya dumb bitch. I was gonna let ya do things the easy way. The fun way. If you'd asked me nicely, I would've let ya have all the money and funding ya wanted. But you got *greedy*. So Mister Nice Satan? He's gone now. This is the *real* Satan talking now."

One of Satan's Vectors squeezed Ose's broken arm. She let out a helpless cry of pain, while tears poured from her eyes. Even with all her mental speed and acuity, she still couldn't believe how fast the situation had turned around. She'd planned this coup for years! She'd thought about every detail! How could she have overlooked one of Satan's core abilities?!

"From now on, your ass is mine. If I tell you to do somethin', you do it. It even overrides that quadruple-titted bitch of a demoness you call 'mom.' Any back-talkin', any thoughts about takin' over, or causing my empire problems, and I'll be payin' you a visit. Only this next visit won't end as nicely as it does here. You'll be dead afterward, and I'll just find some other demon who knows how to play the game right and proper. GOT IT?!"

Satan squeezed her hair so hard that Ose thought he might rip it from her scalp. She winced in pain and whimpered quietly.

"Y...yes... Satan... s-sorry... won't... happen again..."

Satan glared at her for several seconds afterward. Then, he let go.

All at once, his Vectors loosed their hold on her limbs, and he even released his grip on her hair. He allowed Ose to curl up on the floor, whimpering in pain as her entire body ached from head to toe. His Vectors had not been gentle with their touch.

"Good." Satan said solemnly. "Now, let me tell you where ya went wrong. My power ain't just to revive, and it ain't only to devour a soul when I do. I become progressively stronger each time I die. The power boost ain't permanent. I'll be back to having a weak little body soon enough."

Satan chuckled evilly. "But that don't matter, now does it? If you don't kill me, I'll hit you with my arsenal of powers. If you do kill me, I'll eventually return and overpower you. Your momma must not have told you. That's why she doesn't dare go up against me. I might not be invincible, but I'm definitely undefeatable."

Ose shakily looked up at Satan with fear in her eyes. She never imagined he had such an ability. If she had, she would have stayed quiet and kept to herself! But now, she'd alerted the First Emperor to her true ambitions.

Or perhaps she hadn't. What if he'd known from the very beginning? What if he'd at least suspected she'd try to assassinate him... but he didn't even care?!

That thought left her in a cold sweat. She had a chance before to prove her allegiance to him, and she'd sabotaged it. Now he knew more about her inner thoughts than she wanted, and her ploy had completely backfired.

Ose's face slumped to the ground. She stared ahead vacantly, no longer sure of what she should do.

Satan, seeing that her spirit had been broken, finally eased up. "Aw, come on, girly. Don't be like that. I was young and dumb once, too. Nothin' wrong with having some ambition, eh? No reason to throw the imp out with the bathwater. You just gotta do better in the future and not piss me off. Plenty of other demons screwed up big like you, but they learned their lesson. Bent the knee. Now we ain't got no problems anymore. We're cool as ice."

Ose slowly nodded. She had never felt as humiliated during her entire life as at this very moment. Slowly, she pulled herself to a sitting position and pressed her back against the wall. Her arm roared with pain, but she disabled her neurological transmitters so she wouldn't be distracted. Then, she took a long, slow breath.

"You... did you know? From the beginning?" Ose asked.

"What? That you'd betray me? I mean, there's always a risk when other Emperors are involved." Satan said, stuffing his hands into his pockets and shrugging nonchalantly. "You ain't the first dumb bitch to try, and you won't be the last, capisce?"

Ose's eyes dulled. He hadn't known, but he also hadn't cared. She might be intelligent when it came to some matters, but Satan was far older than her. He knew how other Sentients thought. He understood the hearts and minds of his lessers. He knew how to control them, and he was always prepared for things to go sideways.

She had a long way to go.

"So... what now?" Ose asked glumly.

Satan cocked an eyebrow. "Well, first things first, I busted that arm up pretty good. Go see if Hellga has a spot in the Blood Pits. She'll get you all fixed up."

"No need." Ose said quietly. "I already have a healing device of my own."

"Ohoho? Miss fancy-pants is gonna heal herself? Well, don't let me keep you waitin', sister." Satan said, before turning and walking away. "You get right on that."

He took a few steps, then paused.

"By the way, what was all that stuff about building a better future for demons? You got some sort of plan?"

Ose flinched. "You... heard?"

"Nope. I was dead when you said it." Satan said, turning to look at her. "But the demons you killed with your little stunt earlier, well, their souls went in me, and they tattled on you. So I know the gist of what you were yapping about."

Ose glowered at him. "It doesn't matter anymore."

"Sure it does. What, you think I'm petty? You think I don't have demonkind's greater interests at heart?" Satan asked pointedly. "Tell you what. After you get your arm fixed up... sit down for a while and think about what it is you want. What you *really* want. None

of that self-serving bullshit. Then, I want you to write up some plans for the future. Draft 'em for me, then pay me a visit. I'll have a look and see what I can do."

Ose continued to stare at him. "Don't toy with me."

"I'm one hundred percent serious." Satan said, his voice solemn. "It's just you and me here, toots. Nobody else watchin'. I could parade you back into those Blood Pits, make a mockery of you like you did to me. Trample on your dignity. All that crap. But what would that do to benefit demonkind? *Nothing*."

Satan spread out his arms.

"You can keep treating me like an obstacle. Like a barrier to achieving your goals. *Or*, you can try working with me. Who knows? Maybe I'll surprise you."

Ose's anger softened, even if only a little. Satan could tell that he had beaten her so badly her pride had been injured more than her body ever was. But, he was making headway. His words were having some impact.

Ose remained quiet for a few seconds. She looked away from him, at the far wall. Then she held up her good arm, touched her forehead, and condensed some electrical energy onto her pointer finger.

"Take this." Ose said quietly.

She pointed her finger at Satan. He didn't tense up even in the slightest as an incredibly weak 'attack' fired at his forehead. It harmlessly struck his skull, then faded away. For a few moments, Satan remained silent. Then, his expression darkened.

"This... you're sure?" Satan asked, narrowing his eyes.

"No I'm not. It's just a working theory." Ose said quietly, looking away. "I'll let you draw your own conclusions. He's not what he seems. Don't be fooled."

Satan looked to the right, then the left, as if searching for something. It seemed as if he'd become aware of a Truth that was hiding in plain sight before.

"I'll be... more careful about what I say in the future." Satan said cryptically. "Looks like I was right to keep you around. Take care of yourself, Ose."

Just as he was about to leave, Satan instead smirked at her.

"Or should I say... *Emperor of Fusion*?"

Ose met his gaze. She smirked back at him.

"I like that title." She said. "I like it *a lot*."

Then, Satan left. Ose picked herself up, cradled her broken arm, and followed after him.

Things had not gone according to her original plan. She had suffered a humiliating defeat. She had been put in her place.

But then again… maybe it was *better* this way.

Part 640: Peasants! Mere Peasants!

January 25th, 2021. Time Unknown. Location Unknown.

A young man screamed in pain. His body seized up, and he lay on his bed for several seconds, writhing in agony. Then, after the pain wore off, he breathed heavily, swallowed hard, and gritted his teeth.

"**Implant!** Gaaahhh!!! Fffffuck! FUCK!"

Jason Hiro clutched the side of his head. Madam Mildred stood beside the bed, watching him closely while holding onto a strange spiritual 'wire' tethered to his Mind Realm. She monitored the progress of his MindCore's construction while nodding to herself every so often.

"Ninety-five percent complete. Hang in just a while longer, dear boy."

Tears streamed from Jason's eyes. His pillow had long ago been soaked through from his unstoppable sobs of pain. Never had he suffered such horrors in all his life. It was as if he were not only allowing someone else to stab his brain with knives, but being forced to encourage them to stab him even faster.

"Hurts... hurts so much!" Jason exclaimed for perhaps the hundredth time. "No! Why does it hurt this much? Why? Why???"

"You know why. Stop delaying." Mildred said. "The more you drag this out, the longer your suffering will last. We can't stop once we've begun. Now hurry up!"

Jason remained silent for several seconds. His father stood on the opposite side of the bed, his palms crossed in front of his waist. Hideki's role was simple. As the only corporeal entity in this time-accelerated realm, he had to make sure Jason didn't thrash around and fall off the bed, injuring himself severely. Other than that, all he could do was wait and watch.

Even when he wasn't actively Wordsmithing to complete the next step of his Mind Realm's upgrade, Jason's torture continued. It never stopped. Until the GenesisFrame was completed, his mind would be in a permanent state of cyber-psychosis, leaving him totally vulnerable to enemy attack. He wouldn't be able to think properly, and would be at the mercy of anyone who held ill intentions.

Mildred transmitted another data pulse into Jason's Mind Realm. "Next, the Quantum Transistors."

Her voice held no playfulness. She took this assignment as seriously as anyone ever could. Mildred might be a bit of a jovial lady, but she did not want to be responsible for the mental collapse of humanity's mightiest Trueborn. Jason's survival was paramount. He had already endured ten time-accelerated days of sleeplessness. Now, he was in the final hours of completing his MindCore.

Jason trembled. He squeezed his eyes shut, hazily envisioning the blueprints Mildred sent his way. Then he spoke through his teeth.

"**F...FORM!**"

Inside his Mind Realm, a supercomputer unlike any other existed in a state between corporeal and incorporeal. Tens of millions of 'cables' traveled in any number of directions, traversing between the imaginary realm of his Mind, and the physical realm of his Brain. They plugged into specific neurons inside his brain, allowing for the perfect and efficient transfer of information between the physical and metaphysical universe.

At once, the GenesisFrame momentarily became corporeal as tens of thousands of nearly invisible transistors trapped between quantum states appeared all throughout its mainframe. Then, it turned ghostly again, and pulses of mana fired into Jason's brain, making him scream in pain once more.

"Aaaargh! Ah-ah-ahhhh! No more! No! No more!!"

"Just hold on!" Hideki shouted, encouraging his son. "You're so close, Jason! So close!"

"Ninety-five percent!" Mildred repeated. "You've made it this far! Don't die on me now, dear boy!"

Mildred chewed her lip. She looked at Hideki, but he didn't meet her gaze.

Has Cat Mask rewound time at all? Mildred stealthily wondered. *Perhaps the procedure failed and this is the second time? The third? Maybe the hundredth? Or it might even be the first. I don't know if it will work or not, but I must have faith!*

In truth, the GenesisFrame was far more complex than Jason's old mental supercomputer. That one, designed by his wife, had been upgraded piecemeal over the years. Fiona was a genius, but she was no Mildred. She designed it like a plug-and-play

computer system, adding more capacity, storage space, memory speed, and other enhancements over a long period of time. The final product was definitely superior to Jason's physical brain, but in theory, it wasn't one percent as fearsome as Mildred's MindCore. Hers was designed to work together in perfect harmony, without any bottlenecks, each piece of the machine as focused and enhanced as it could ever possibly be. The only way she could improve it further was if she were to tap into the brain or brains of several high ranking Volgrim Technopaths.

Perhaps with their deep understanding of technology, Mildred might be able to upgrade Jason's GenesisFrame a thousand times beyond the design she had currently envisioned.

But that was only a possibility for a tentative future. Mildred refocused her thoughts and efforts on the subject at hand.

"Next data-burst." Mildred said authoritatively, transmitting the next step of the GenesisFrame's construction to Jason. "Focus! Bear with the pain! Remember your wife!"

Jason nodded weakly. He felt as if he had lost all the blood in his body. His bones seemed to have lost ninety percent of their density. Even the simple act of breathing made him want to die.

"Phoe...be..." Jason whimpered.

* * *

Five more hours passed.

"This is it!" Mildred exclaimed, her voice raising an octave. "The final step! We're almost there, Jason! Now... do it! Complete the device!"

Jason lay unmoving on the bed. His consciousness wavered in and out of reality. The world around him... seemed so distant.

None of this was worth it.

He just... wanted... to go to sleep.

Sleep.

He could see Phoebe again. In the next life.

They could be together once more.

Jason's eyes began to close.

His eyelids felt... so heavy...

"Son." Hideki said, leaning forward. The man's expression was as dark as the night. "Don't give up. You'll do it this time. Come on."

He gently touched Jason's face. The Wordsmith... didn't respond.

Cat Mask closed his eyes.

"Another failure."

Mildred's heart jumped. What did he mean by-

"No..." Jason said, his voice barely audible. "Can't... give... up..."

His cloudy eyes regained the tiniest hint of light. He coughed, and blood spilled from his mouth. "Must... finish... must... must..."

Cat Mask leaned forward. His body vibrated for a moment, then he brought his face within inches of his son.

"One last push, kid. Come on. For Daisy. For your *little girl*."

Jason closed his eyes. He swallowed a shallow breath...

Then his body stiffened.

"**Man...if... manif... MANIFEST!**"

A faint light sparked within his Mind Realm. A massive burst of data shot out of the wire Mildred was holding on to, electrocuting her spirit and making her shriek in pain. She quickly dropped the spiritual anchor and looked at the Wordsmith with shining eyes.

"It's done?!" She asked.

Jason lay there, unmoving. But his breathing became less labored. His body shook, not with pain, but with the feeling of exhaustion.

His Mind Realm became reinvigorated. His GenesisFrame fully manifested into reality.

The procedure was a success!

Jason didn't celebrate. He didn't even seem aware of what had happened. Instead, he fell fast asleep, the exhaustion of a ten day procedure completely swallowing his mind.

Hideki continued to stare at his son's face from a few inches away. Then, he smiled and stood up.

"It worked." Hideki said, more to himself than anyone else.

Mildred looked at Hideki. This time, he met her gaze.

"How... how many times did we perform the procedure?" Mildred asked, a lump in her throat.

Hideki remained quiet for a moment.

"Just once." He lied.

Jason slept for two days. He awoke slowly, his body still weak with exhaustion, and a fever burning his forehead. His skull seemed molten, like it was trying to contain a volcano. His vision blurred, and what faint hazy figures he could make out seemed so very, very distant. Voices crept into his ears. He blearily felt that this moment was eerily similar to so many times in the past when he had suffered horrible concussions.

He pulled himself to a sitting position, then stared ahead in a daze.

The Wordsmith couldn't quite... couldn't... couldn't remember... what was he doing? Who was he? Where was he?

His mind whirred into action.

Jason Hiro. Wordsmith. Ability to manifest Words of Power into reality. Current location: Secret time accelerated realm. Current realspace date and time: January 25th, 5:46 PM assuming West Coast USA time zone.

He nodded, the motion making his head swim with delirium. "Ohhh... thass... hellfull..."

After thinking for a moment, Jason asked himself another question.

[I feel like shit. How do I... not? Feel like shit.]

Analysis of current condition. Suffering from pain-induced psychosis. Severe delirium as a result of newly installed hardware attached to cerebellum. Incorrect attachment points are creating a negative feedback loop. Suggestion: Realignment via Word of Power. New attachment points suggested here, here, and here.

[Oh. So it's like that.]

"**Realign.**" Jason said.

Inside his brain, something unseen by the outside world changed. Jason's vision sharpened, and the world around him came into focus. Just like that, his fever dropped, and his thinking realigned.

"Hm? You Wordsmithed?" Mildred asked, still standing next to him. "I'm glad to see you awake, dear boy. You weren't responding to anything I said."

Jason looked at her. His eyes were sharper than before.

"Sorry, Mildred." Jason said. "It seemed to be a cerebral misalignment with the polymolecule cables. They were attached to the incorrect dendrites, causing me to suffer a severe fever that likely would have- what? Why are you looking at me like that?"

Mildred gaped at the young man, then quickly closed her mouth. "I... I just... amazing! Ho-ho-ho! It really worked, young Wordsmith! This beauty is truly a genius! My inventions are unparalleled!"

Jason nodded. He suddenly recalled what he'd just said.

"Whoa. I don't usually talk like that. I feel like my vocabulary has increased substantially."

Another Hero walked into the room.

"Good to see you awake, child." Jepthath said, crossing his arms. The spiritual ancestor nodded as he assessed Jason's condition. "You gave us several scares, but it seems you pulled through. How are you feeling?"

Jason started to answer, but for some reason, he felt his attention being drawn to a bedside table on his right. He kept looking at it and frowning.

"Something the matter?" Jepthath asked.

"I don't know." Jason said, swinging his legs over the side of the bed while looking at the table more intently. "I Wordsmithed this? It's so... ugly."

Jepthath blinked. He didn't really understand how the topic of discussion had landed on, of all things, a bedside table.

"Don't you think we should talk about more pressing issues?" Jepthath asked. He looked at Mildred, but she seemed just as perplexed by Jason's behavior. She shrugged at her fellow ancestor.

"It's just... *man*, this thing is so ugly. So sloppy." Jason grumbled. "It looks completely artificial and fake. When I made it, I clearly didn't put any effort into aesthetics. I simply Wordsmithed the simplest and most basic-looking bedside table that came to mind. It's a square! Doesn't even have any flared edges on top, the legs are mere stumps sticking out of the bottom, and it's all one piece. No real carpenter would craft something this ugly. They'd assemble it using multiple hand-made pieces, gluing them, nailing them, pressing them together. Doesn't it just disgust you to look at?"

Jason looked at his ancestors for validation, but they gave him looks of confusion in response.

"...Again, this hardly seems important." Jepthath said slowly.

"Well, it's important to me." Jason muttered, turning back to the table. "One moment."

Instantly, Jason analyzed the table's structure. Dozens of nails, wooden slabs, internal drawer frames, and even a stained and patterned surface materialized in his head. As if drawing a three-dimensional blueprint with just his mind, he crafted a completely new bedside table vastly different and much more artisanal than the one before him. Then, he squinted and looked at the existing one.

"**Replace.**"

The small table blurred in place. A faint aura of white light covered its appearance, then thousands of individual pieces materialized in reality, rapidly colliding together and assembling a brand new bedside table in the same spot as before. To Jepthath and Mildred, it almost looked as if a horde of invisible carpenters were rebuilding the table piece by piece at superliminal speeds, drilling screws into place, applying glue, realigning individual components, until...

The new bedside table manifested in reality. Jason sat there for a moment looking at it, then he abruptly stood up, losing all interest in the beautiful new piece of carpentry he had just assembled.

"Thank god." Jason mumbled. "Way too ugly. Distractingly so. Anyway, what are we working on now?"

He was met with two ancestors, both trying to pull their jaws up from the floor.

"I... Jason, are you feeling alright, dear boy?" Mildred asked, after a few moments of hesitation. "You seem... very different from before..."

Jason scoffed. "What, you see a guy build a table and lose your minds? It's just a table. Come on, I've been missing out on developments in meatspace because of the operation."

He started to walk away, then paused and looked down at his white T-shirt and sweatpants. His expression turned ugly.

"God. What the hell am I wearing? So sloppy. One second..."

A moment later, Jason Wordsmithed again. "**Clothes.**"

Instead of his signature T-shirt and jeans, which he had worn in various colors for years, Jason donned a noticeably snazzier long sleeved black shirt made of cashmere that also sported lines of gold trim traveling from the collar down the sleeves, along with some elastic jeans in a similar color pattern. His clothes weren't only more impressive looking, but they seemed to go extremely well with his physical build, and they also had armor woven into them. A bullet to the chest would ricochet right off the mysterious material compromising his new sweater.

"It'll do for now." Jason muttered to himself, still somewhat disgusted with his 'rudimentary' clothes. "Really going to need to put some thought into a new wardrobe later. Can't go walking around looking like a total dump now, can I?"

Mildred and Jepthath exchanged glances once more.

Jason was acting very different from before the operation. Mildred naturally assumed a cognitive boost would affect his personality... but to *this* extent? Even she was surprised.

* * *

Jason stepped into the main chamber, where his Spynet was running, his father sitting in front of the computer screens, sipping coffee. Every time Jason looked at any object, no matter how complex or benign, his expression shifted to one of pain and disgust, making it constantly look like hideous, naked invisible people were slapping him across the face one after the other.

"What the hell was wrong with me?" Jason grumbled to himself, as Mildred and Jepthath followed behind him, gradually growing accustomed to his verbal outbursts. "This shit is so ass. Why did I make these monitors so low-resolution? I can do better

than that. And the optimization of camera placements? Abysmal. The angles are all wrong. Oh, hey dad."

Hideki turned away from the monitors to look at his son. "Good morning, Jason. Huh. Nice clothes."

Jason grimaced. "Don't. Just don't. They're barely passable for now. I'm already feeling rather *wretched* just wearing them."

Hideki blinked. "Okay. Want to hear what happened while you were asleep?"

Jason nodded. "I'm all ears."

Hideki changed one of the monitors and started telling Jason about Ose's ascension to Emperor. Jason frowned, making Hideki think he didn't like this news. Actually, it turned out Jason truly detested looking at that imperfect and ugly monitor. It was just so inefficient. The energy waste alone! Why did he copy crappy 21st century monitors when he could steal and improve on Volgrim tech? Was his previous self *stupid*?

"Yeah, yeah, Ose's an Emperor now." Jason said, holding up his hand to stop his father mid-sentence. "Hold on, just a sec. I can't stand these ugly fucking computer monitors, not for a second longer. I mean seriously? Sixty hertz? What kind of refresh speed is that anyway? Are these monitors for peasants??"

Inside Jason's mind, a blueprint of the original monitors appeared. A phantasmal version of Jason appeared before that blueprint, and began ripping it apart and putting it back together at blinding speeds. New components rapidly disassembled and reassembled. Transistors and circuit boards drastically improved. Jason even casually started uttering Words of Power midway through, peeking out across the vastness of space to look at the distant world of Volgarius. He stole a few thousand other designs for new monitors, took a look at them, grimaced as if he were about to vomit, and made casual modifications to unify them all together.

After that, Jason looked at the array of Spynet monitors, then spoke a Word of Power. "**Rebuild.**"

Within twenty real-time seconds, every monitor disassembled and reassembled itself. Ethereal components manifested into reality. Hideki watched with marveling eyes as the entire Spynet visual component became whole again, reflecting the same images as before. Only, now...!

Hideki squinted. "Err... did anything change?"

"What do you mean?" Jason asked, narrowing his eyes. "Can't you see the difference? Look at the fidelity! I cut the power draw by 99.9%! I created several new exotic alloys just to reduce power consumption alone, and then I increased the resolution from 1080p to a number that human marketing conventions can't capture. On top of that, the displays now refresh over a million times per second! We can monitor the galaxy with a level of quality even eagle eyes couldn't match!"

Cat Mask nodded slowly. "Oh, alright. That's really neat, son."

"Can you SERIOUSLY not see the difference?!" Jason roared. "It's so obvious! What are you, a peasant?!"

Hideki looked at his son, then shrugged. "I don't know. It all looks the same to me. But if you're happy, I'm happy."

"Oh my god..." Jason muttered, his expression turning downcast. He seemed to age five years in an instant. He turned away, his face an amalgamation of horror. "This... is this how Ose feels, every moment of every day? Doomed for nobody to appreciate the perfection of her designs?!"

Mildred inhaled softly. She gently facepalmed.

"Oh, my dear boy. We are going to need to have a *long*, hard talk about your new capabilities."

Part 641: The Curse of Intellect

January 25th, 2021. Time Unknown. Location Unknown.

At Mildred's request, Jason eventually sat down, but not before completely rebuilding the chair he was about to sit in, cleaning up its appearance in seconds and making it more aesthetically pleasing and ergonomically comfortable. After that, he settled in and turned a distracted gaze toward her.

"Well?" Jason asked impatiently. "What's the matter?"

"Jason." Mildred explained patiently. "Right now, you are experiencing extreme stress due to the cognitive boosts provided by your GenesisFrame. I need you to try and calm down, dear boy. Relax for a moment. Close your eyes. Take a long, deep breath."

Jason frowned. "Huh? Why even bother? I'm fine. There's just SO many problems to fix! I'm surrounded by reminders of my former laziness! It's impossible to focus!"

Mildred held up her palm. "I know some of the problems of which you speak. When you are able to look at the world around you with a critical eye, you can be overcome with feelings of hatred, disgust, and eventually despondency. This is the curse of intelligence. It plagues many great minds, and now it is plaguing you. The difference is, entities like myself, Solomon, Raphael, and Ose all gradually gained intellect over time and adapted to it. You have amassed too much, too quickly. It is overloading your emotional centers."

Jason fidgeted in his seat. He kept looking around the room, scowling nonstop while also trying to listen to what she was saying, albeit without a great deal of success. "Right, right... emotional centers... uh huh... look, can this wait? I need to-"

"JASON!" Mildred barked, making him flinch in his seat. "Pay attention!"

The Wordsmith looked at her in shock. "What? WHAT? Why are you yelling?! Calm down!"

Despite his surprise, Mildred's gambit succeeded. She managed to fully bring all his attention onto her.

"Listen carefully, dear boy." Mildred explained succintly. Your GenesisFrame is a powerful machine. It is currently tuned to its highest sensitivity, overloading your mind

with stimuli. You need to drastically dial down its settings, only increasing them over time. Do you understand?"

Jason finally listened. He slowly nodded, then thought for a moment. "I didn't realize I could do that. Hmm. One moment..."

It only took a single second, and Jason was able to adjust the power consumption and load on his cerebral cortex. Just like that, the tension in his body immediately alleviated a great deal, albeit not completely. He looked around the room, still noticed some of the imperfections around himself, but paid less attention to them.

"That was... a miserable experience." Jason muttered.

"A child raised in the jungle their whole life would have a similar reaction to suddenly being placed in a crowded subway with thousands of people speaking at once." Mildred explained. "Too much stimuli can be extremely dangerous for one who has not acclimated to lesser levels properly. That being said, we can confirm your GenesisFrame is functioning properly. Your cognitive speed and thought quality has improved drastically."

Jason nodded. "This feels like an upgrade over my old MindCore in every way. It seems like I can do anything I put my mind to, now."

He looked thoughtful for a moment, but Mildred interrupted his internal dialogue with a dose of reality.

"Unfortunately, dear boy, that is not the case. If you attempt to use your powers of prediction like you did before, your GenesisFrame will certainly perform better than a baseline brain, but it will not compare to your original MindCore."

She continued to explain. "Your GenesisFrame is tightly focused on inventions, creativity, construction, deconstruction, and other things related to physical and metaphysical phenomena. It is not particularly suited for battle, nor for reading the emotional states of other Sentients. Naturally, it is still superior to any baseline human's brain. You are definitely going to feel and act more intelligently than before. But compared to a proper MindCore focused on other such things, it will not beat them in their specialization."

Jason sat silently for a minute or two. He thought to himself about a great many things, then slowly massaged his ear between his fingers.

"I think... you're underestimating what this particular MindCore can do." Jason said slowly. "I don't have the constraints other people do. They would not only need to visualize and think about inventing something, but then actually build it with their own two hands."

He looked at Mildred with a serious gaze. "I can visualize something, then create it nearly instantly with my Wordsmithing. There are limitations, of course... but I can essentially make use of the GenesisFrame's full capabilities at 99% efficiency."

To emphasize his point, Jason closed his eyes. With a single mental command, he reactivated the GenesisFrame at full power. His mind started to tingle, but he ignored all the abrupt, forced thoughts about things that should be annoying him in his environment, then turned his attention to a singular concept.

In a flash, a sword began to appear inside his Mind Realm. It started off simple. A basic handle, hilt, and blade. After that, the blade became thinner. Its weight balance shifted, and the handle also changed as he began altering its material composition.

Rapid-fire, Jason started trying out different quantities of iron, steel, titanium, tungsten, and many other common alloys. Then, with his knowledge of different sorts of Wordsmithium, he altered the blade again, and again, and again.

Unlike with the chairs, table, or computer monitors, this mental project did not take only a few seconds to complete. Instead, a minute dragged on. Then two minutes. Five...

Time accelerated inside his Mind Realm. Jason became frustrated and stymied as he tried adjusting parts of this new sword, only to repeatedly come up short due to his lack of knowledge in blacksmithing, metallurgy, and other such topics.

He opened his eyes. He stood up and frowned.

"Hm. Not quite right." Jason said, turning the GenesisFrame's settings back down to a low-power mode. He met Mildred's gaze. "I'm lacking in knowledge."

"As I expected." Mildred immediately retorted. "You cannot create new paradigms until your existing knowledge-base has been shored up. Simply put, you need to do some reading, child! Reading, study, perhaps even attending college or university."

Jason looked displeased. "I don't have time for that."

"Time waits for no man," Mildred acknowledged, "but studying essential concepts will empower your GenesisFrame tremendously."

Jason thought for a minute. He wandered around the Spynet, thinking to himself while occasionally glancing at the monitors.

"...*Nah*." Jason finally concluded, waving his hand. "Studying will take way too long. I have a better way."

Jason once again reactivated his GenesisFrame at full capacity. He closed his eyes so the outside world wouldn't distract him, then he focused on thinking about Wordsmithing.

Before long, a hazy idea became reality. An invisible bodysuit appeared in front of his mental-self. The false Jason rapidly traveled around it, his arms and hands moving at lightning fast speeds as he cut, trimmed, and manipulated the suit to add microtechnology and magical artifacts to it.

After five minutes of concentrated thinking time, the suit was completed. Jason wasted no time in uttering a Word of Power.

"**Materialize. Shape. Form.**"

Mildred narrowed her eyes. She perceived... *something* that appeared in midair for a split second, before silently falling to the ground. Her existence as a spiritual life-form made her more sensitive to such phenomena, but she could not actually see what Jason had just made.

Jason looked at the ground, his eyes fixating on seemingly nothing. "**Wear.**"

An instant later... Jason disappeared!

One second, he was standing before Mildred.

The next, he completely vanished, as if he had teleported away!

Mildred widened her eyes. She squinted, feeling that Jason was... still in the same spot... perhaps. But she wasn't entirely certain...

Then, Jason's face seemingly poked out of a hole in the air. The rest of his body was completely hidden, but his face was somehow visible.

"It's a new type of stealth suit." Jason explained. "It has all sorts of magical technology built into it. My ability to create weapons and armor is subpar, but magical-based technology isn't too difficult. This stealth suit should allow me to move around, undisturbed."

Mildred looked at him with wonder in her eyes. She couldn't believe how amazing this single item was... and he had made it with only a few minutes of thought! What other incredible feats could he achieve in the future once his GenesisFrame had matured and he'd grown even better at using its capabilities?

"What do you need a stealth suit for?" Mildred eventually asked. "Don't tell me you're going to try assassinating demons already?!"

"No, definitely not." Jason replied, his face still bobbing up and down oddly in the air. "Right now, I have a critical lack of knowledge. I need to remedy this issue at once. I'm going to infiltrate several key facilities around the world as quietly as possible. This suit is equipped with technology and magic-foiling stealth systems. It should perform excellently at obfuscating my movements."

Mildred nodded, but she seemed unconvinced. "I can pass you my knowledge, dear boy. It's not too difficult. I have a wealth of information at my disposal I've collected over the years! Sadly, I am nowhere near as adept as Solomon. His information and intelligence reserves greatly dwarf mine."

"Yeah, I don't doubt the *Knowledge-Thief* who scares the Volgrim shitless has more information than you." Jason remarked idly. "I'll be back in a bit."

Jason's face disappeared as he retreated into his stealth suit. A moment later, he entirely vanished from the spot.

* * *

Inside the United States Library of Congress, an invisible specter teleported into a quiet corner of one of the interior rooms. It started slowly walking around, using magic to mass-read and swallow entire shelves of books in seconds.

This specter was none other than Jason. Using Words of Power, he downloaded millions of words every minute, starting from the local history section and quickly working his way outward.

It took him time to do this, time he'd rather not waste. But it was necessary. His GenesisFrame was not like Solomon's Crown; it did not have unlimited storage capacity. But even a trillion books wouldn't take up that much of its room. Only extremely complicated audiovisual works, such as music, movies, and the life memories of other Sentients would rapidly fill up its capacity.

Even so, Jason already had an idea of how to fix this problem.

External data storage!

He could easily copy important things worth keeping into a massive data cluster hidden somewhere in the Milky Way. It could be in Realspace, or it could be hidden inside a folded dimension. Either way, he could shove essentially an infinite amount of information there, only connecting to it when he needed its contents for a new project.

This was not a quick project, but a long-term one. All he was doing today was rapidly collecting most of human civilization's core information. Later, he would use it for his own purposes. Eventually, he could transform humanity's collective knowledge into a cudgel to beat the demons into submission!

If they didn't submit, they would die.

Jason's heart no longer held any compassion for other species. He had lost everything he valued. No longer would he take risks with the lives of his loved ones.

He flitted from room to room, taking to the air to silently levitate above the thousands of daily visitors the Library of Congress received. A lot of them were lawyers and judges, but there were also reporters, ordinary citizens, and tourists too. This time of year, it was rather cold outside, so people entered to warm themselves, but during the summer foot traffic would easily quintuple.

Jason was lucky that he could come here while so few people were around.

As he devoured the contents of a shelf of books regarding historical blacksmithing practices, a television in the corner played a news broadcast.

"President Johannesburg's agenda is considered controversial by his critics, but he continues to press on with his Ecuadorian Eclipse Act, insisting it will bring jobs back to the United States. After the failed policies of his predecessor, President Johannesburg has a lot to prove. Thanks to excellent strategies employed by his campaign staff, he's swept the House of Representatives, holding a forty-seat majority, but unfortunately he lost the Senate by two seats. Only time will tell if this ends up obstructing him from realizing his vision of the American Dream."

Jason glanced at the monitor. He had long forgotten about the politics of this era after living for hundreds of years in the future. And when he was a kid, worrying about politics was the last thing on his mind.

Even so, he knew that a time would come, sooner rather than later, where he had to meet with the so-called leader of the free world.

This prospect would have been extremely intimidating, even outright terrifying to the version of himself who had only left the Cryopod for a few years. He was younger and far less experienced back then.

But these days?

Eh.

What was meeting a 'President' compared to meeting the true leader of the Milky Way, a multi-million year old monster named Unarin?

In Jason's eyes, the President was a mere mortal. He held some political power, but it paled in comparison to Jason's hard powers of magic.

Jason paused his book-collecting to think for a few moments. With his accelerated brainpower, this was like taking an hour to ponder the matter ever so casually at a coffee shop.

Was the president a mere mortal? What did the demons think about him? Did they fear him? Laugh at him? Find him annoying but nothing to worry about? He commanded the strongest human military in the world, so he couldn't be *nothing*.

And then again, Jason quickly realized he had no real knowledge of what humanity's military capabilities truly were. What if they were much stronger than they seemed on the surface? What if the humans possessed weapons and technology that could make a Demon Emperor pause? That meant it could threaten the Wordsmith as well.

Interlocking pieces of a puzzle slowly snapped together in Jason's mind. Unfortunately, despite his incredible new brainpower, he realized that Mildred was right. He was no longer as effective at deductive reasoning as before. He had respecialized into an inventor, someone who could create blueprints for his Wordsmithing to bounce off. When it came to investigating conspiracies, he was rather... subpar.

I'm still faster than a normal human, and my baseline self, but it's nothing too amazing. Jason thought. *Right now, I'm setting up my plans, but the existing humans, the demons, angels, and Titans have had thousands of years to build their own infrastructure while I'm starting from scratch. I can borrow the manpower of the Illuminati, but they're small potatoes compared to the US military*.

Jason watched as the broadcast turned to a story about flooding in Indonesia. His vision wavered as the faces of injured children, sick mothers and fathers, and broken families reached his eyes.

So much suffering. So much pain. Jason thought. *What am I really doing all this for? Just to dominate and control? No. That cannot be the only reason. Phoebe would hate me if she knew I had turned into a tyrant. I need a more noble cause to focus my intent. Uplifting humanity so we can defeat the demons, overthrow the Volgrim, and humble the angels is merely one piece of the puzzle. All that would happen is my species swapping from the oppressed to the oppressors.*

We need to become better than we are now.

Jason turned his eyes toward the windows outside, where he could peek at a small slice of Washington DC. There were a couple of girls sitting on a bench, sipping cocoa and talking about their day.

Inside the library, a young man was studying the history of Robert E. Lee for an upcoming college assignment. His brow knitted together in frustration as the dense and boring historical information bogged down by overly gratuitous and flowery wording struggled to burrow into his brain.

A professor of anthropology grumbled to himself about the kids these days while sipping an iced mocha latte. His mustache became wet with the liquid as it slipped between the gaps in his facial hair to enter his mouth.

All these people were individuals living their own lives. It was far too easy for Jason to take a broad view of them, looking at them like cats that needed to be herded.

A debate raged inside Jason's mind. Were humans mostly good, with sociological and economic pressures pushing them to do bad things? Or were they mostly bad, only kept in line by the firm and guiding hands of higher authorities?

This was not an easy question to answer. It wasn't a mere philosophical thought, either. How he answered it would surely affect the way he looked at and treated his fellow humans. It would alter his plans for the future, and this could lead to a disaster in the future, causing even more pain and suffering to those he ultimately wished to protect.

Jason raised his head to look at the ceiling. The Library of Congress was the world's largest library, with tall rising pillars, stained glass windows with grandiose designs, and

architecture that bled elegance everywhere he looked. It was a shining pillar of what humans could accomplish when they used their minds to create art in the form of architecture.

As he looked around himself at this impressive feat of human engineering, Jason felt that humanity... couldn't be all that bad.

It had tyrants. It had dictators. It had authoritarians who sought to force their will upon others.

But it had far more good people, working tirelessly for little to no gain only to make the Earth a better place. Ornithologists who studied endangered birds and worked to protect them from extinction. Oceanographers who pushed and lobbied for cleanup efforts to save the oceans from ecological collapse. Climatologists who mapped the planet's slowly increasing heat index as humans carelessly polluted it for short term gains.

The number of bad people were far outnumbered by the good. But the bad people held a monopoly on violence, using their power to suppress those less eager to jump to using such vile tactics. In this way, they had slowly wrapped their hands around the necks of their more peaceful peers.

Perhaps, in a different era, these tactics would be necessary. After all, it took great strength to hold back the demons, angels, and Titans.

But the Wordsmith was here, now. It might finally be time to upend the old paradigm and install a new one.

I can't just casually throw away all the 'bad' people right now. Jason thought. *They still have some purpose for me. I need to put them in check. Make them learn who their new master is. Watch them to ensure they can't commit any future atrocities. After that? Who knows. As long as I resist becoming an even worse tyrant, I should be able to raise humanity's spirits to the apex.*

Jason gazed at the ornate stained glass skylights. He couldn't see it, but in his mind's eye, he imagined being able to gaze upon the Volgrim ship currently orbiting Jupiter in absolute secrecy.

There is still so much yet to do. He mused.

With a shake of his head, he returned to devouring the books from before.

Time waited for no man.

Part 642: Collapsing Empire

AUTHOR'S NOTE: Attention readers. I wanted you guys to know that in the near future, I plan to go back through the TCTH serial and start marking the exact day each part takes place. After doing so for the Rewind timeline, I realized I should have been doing this all along. For now, I'm going to start using the term "After Jason's Rewind - AJR" but in the future, once I've actually gone through all the old parts, I'll be using the terms "After Cryopod's Exit - ACE" for keeping track of how many days/years the story progressed following Jason's departure, then I'll use a special term for the Ancient Era too (Maybe something like "After Dragon Empowerment - ADE") or whatever. For now, I'll stick with AJR starting with this part and let you guys know if/when I complete that re-read of TCTH, followed by the marking down of the timeline.

I may also use a specific term for the various timelines like Gold Timeline, Silver Timeline... maybe. But that could spoil new readers about the existence of time travel, which I don't want to do, so... we'll see about that.

Enjoy the return to TCTH!

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. Volgarius.

Founder Unarin stood inside the hangar of the Founder's Thumb, his toes mere inches from the edge of the outcropping that stuck out to allow small starships to land safely inside. He looked up at Volgarius's sky, the planet's wind whipping his head tendrils from side to side as a rather fierce gale buffeted his body. He paid it no mind. No breeze could move him, no matter how fierce, for he was indomitable.

Volgarius's dull, gray sky spoke to any who looked upon it; calling out the horrors of tens of millennia of decay. What was once a beautiful homeworld had slowly collapsed into a featureless blob of metal, glass, and duracrete. Stratoscrapers might look impressive when standing amidst a sea of smaller buildings, but once an entire planet had been covered in them, they lost their impressiveness and instead became a symbol of

destruction. What was once a beautiful world had now become utterly featureless, any given square kilometer of its surface indistinguishable from the rest. All that remained of the Volgrim homeworld's former glory now resided at the Founder's Hand; the last patch of greenery remaining of its original soil.

Unarin's eyes narrowed slightly. His keen eyes picked out a tiny speck in the sky, one that approached at a speed that would alarm him if he didn't already know who it was. Within seconds, Executor Nufaris rushed toward the First Founder, an unconscious body held in his psionic grasp. That body was none other than Founder Dosena.

Nufaris instantly came to a stop right before colliding with the Founder's Thumb. He spun his legs downward and pressed his bare feet against the cold metal floor of the hangar, not feeling its frigid temperature in the slightest.

"Has her condition improved?" Unarin asked, as he walked over and pressed his palm against Dosena's forehead.

[I'm afraid not.] Nufaris replied.

The two men didn't exchange many words. Nufaris fell silent, allowing Unarin to close his eyes while continuing to rest his palm on Dosena's forehead.

Before long, he nodded slowly, then opened his eyes and removed his hand.

"I believe it need not be mentioned, but this is a terrible situation for our Empire, Nufaris." Unarin said, though his vocal tone didn't seem to contain even a hint of worry or urgency. "Dosena is our pillar of strength. Without her, we have no Middle Cosmic, while the demons now consist of many. Trapped they may be on their worlds, but far from useless. Through Demon Deity Yardrat, they already possess a means of projecting power across the galaxy. They are more than capable of rendering unto us extreme harm."

Nufaris knit his eyebrows together. "Your orders?"

Unarin did not immediately respond. He folded his hands together behind his back, then closed his eyes once more to ponder his future plans.

"This is a nexus point for the Volgrim Empire..." Unarin said slowly. "I sense... a potentially disastrous future awaiting us. But at the same time, a chance to reach heights we never have before. Dosena was close. She was so very, very close to reaching the 10th Level. She believed with all her soul that becoming a High Cosmic through pure psionics was possible. But this setback has ruined her prospects for potentially tens of millennia.

She has fallen all the way back to the beginning of the 9th Level. If her condition worsens, she may even fall to the rank of Executor."

Nufaris's expression hardened. This was not something he wanted to hear. Though he, like all Executors, envied the power of the Second Founder, he did not do so while wishing to usurp her power. A strong Dosena meant a strong Empire. He himself was ages away from reaching the 9th Level. He would not be able to replace her even if he tried. Neither did he want to. He had his own ambitions.

Unarin opened his eyes once again. He reached up and massaged his chin thoughtfully.

"It pains me to say so, but we are in a weak position. The Plague on all sides, the demons possessing more military power, the humans injured but having found a new ally in Demon Deity Melody as well as the fairies. They will lick their wounds and recuperate, providing us no threat for the moment... but this stalemate will not last forever. Whether it takes one day or one millennia, the humans will rise again. They have proven themselves to be like unkillable bugs. Even if we try to exterminate them, they will endure."

Nufaris nodded. [Therefore?]

"I do not yet have an answer." Unarin said. "I tend to think in long-term timescales. Too much has happened recently. It has thrown all my future plans into Chaos. I fear there is more going on behind the scenes than what we know. There are enemies in this game who have yet to play their cards."

Unarin held out his arms. Nufaris hesitated, then he levitated Dosena into the First Founder's grasp.

Unarin carried Dosena like a princess. He looked at Nufaris gravely. "Investigate the galactic situation, but stay at the homeworld. You are now our strongest protector. If something should occur, you are our last remaining bulwark."

Nufaris tilted his chin. [First Founder. There is one individual I fear you may have overlooked.]

Unarin blinked. "Who?"

Before Nufaris could respond, Unarin realized who he was referring to.

"You weren't able to recover her?"

[Demila remains at large. She betrayed the Empire.] Nufaris responded. [She might be a pitiful excuse for a Psion, but she is still an ancient monster capable of great destruction. I fear what might happen if we allow her to go into hiding.]

"If she merely hid herself away, I would not be so worried." Unarin said calmly. "There are much worse things she could do right now. If she has aligned herself with the demons, she might provide them with a treasure trove of knowledge about our internal workings."

[We need to execute her.] Nufaris said.

"Yes. Yes we do." Unarin said, before frowning slightly. "But the galaxy is a vast place. Where do you suppose she might go first?"

Nufaris appeared troubled. He looked away.

[I am... not certain. You are more familiar with Demila than I. I hoped you might have an idea of her machinations.]

Unarin lowered his eyes.

"I have always prided myself on seeing through the thoughts of lower beings. But Demila fooled me until the end. I only realized her betrayal was coming when it was already too late. I failed to prepare for her actions, and Dosena paid the price. At this point, I dare not guess at her movements lightly."

[Then we have no choice but to monitor the situation patiently.] Nufaris concluded. [We have already informed the rest of the Empire. If Demila is spotted, we will receive word immediately. I will be able to intercept and kill her.]

"No. Not you." Unarin retorted. "You are to stay here until Dosena has recuperated. We've already lost Sartran to Demon Deity Beelzebub. Our list of reliable allies grows thinner by the day. Dispatch two of the other Executors to hunt down and kill Demila. Use your discretion."

Nufaris bowed his head in respect.

[As you command, First Founder.]

Thousands of lightyears from Volgarius, in a secret location hidden somewhere in the Milky Way, the very Psion Nufaris and Unarin were just discussing levitated in the Void. She stared at a hideous world colored completely brown, one that looked like a ball of

mud, with no noteworthy geographical features, and nothing about it that seemed out of the ordinary.

This world, 'Planet Mudball', as Jason had called it, was actually one of three extremely important Psion bases hidden within the Volgrim Empire. It housed billions, tens of billions, perhaps even trillions of Psion souls.

Its true name was Naandril II, the second of the three great Psion soul-housing worlds.

Demila hid within a gap between dimensions. She gazed at the world with a strange look in her eye.

[**What are you waiting for?**] A female voice hidden within Demila's soul asked. [**This is what you desired. Reach out and take hold of your destiny, Demila.**]

Demila hesitated. Her body trembled with a mixture of fear for future consequences, but also hunger and greed.

[You're... you're sure this will work?] Demila asked.

[**Hahaha. The great Demila, a million years old, but always such a pitiful scared child.**] Desire teased. [**The demons have known this power for a long time. By devouring countless powerful souls, you will amplify yourself to the extreme. You will become a powerhouse of the Volgrim Empire. With Dosena defeated, they will have no choice but to bow their heads and fear your power. You will finally be afforded the respect you deserve.**]

The word 'respect' elicited a strong reaction from Demila. How long had the Executors quietly, or not so quietly, mocked and laughed at her? They saw her as a failure. A pathetic excuse for a Psion who had too many so-called flaws in her foundation. She could no longer take the final step and break into the ranks of the Executors. She was frozen in time while upstarts like Vulpanix and Nufaris matched or exceeded her capabilities.

It was unfair! She had worked herself to the bone, pondered countless Truths, spoken with the ancestors, yet she was still unable to make any progress! How could she be content with her lot in life while others treated her as a joke?

There was only one thing holding her back from taking the plunge and walking the road of no return.

[If I do this, I will become a monster of the Volgrim Empire.] Demila said quietly. [A pariah, hated by all. How do you know I will be able to break through to the rank of

Executor? And even... beyond that?]

[**If you're too scared to try, then don't bother.**] Desire said dismissively, seemingly looking away and losing interest. [**One too corrupted by a fear to move will never become extraordinary. Perhaps Master Gressil was wrong about you. Maybe there never was anything of value about you to begin with...**]

Demila furrowed her brow. [Bah! I'll do it! Never you mind! Just watch and see!]

In an instant, Demila lost her hesitation. She kicked against the emptiness of the Void and launched herself at Naandril II, traveling at superliminal speeds. By the time the Psions on the world detected her approach, it was too late. She struck the topsoil with tremendous force, plowing directly into the planet's crust and smashing her way downward with reckless abandon.

Alarms roared inside the facility.

ALERT. CREATOR DEMILA HAS MADE PLANETFALL ON NAANDRIL II. ALL SECURITY FORCES RESPOND IMMEDIATELY. CONTAIN OR KILL THIS TRAITOR TO THE VOLGRIM EMPIRE. GIVE NO QUARTER. THE FOUNDERS HAVE BEEN ALERTED TO HER PRESENCE.

Demila's eyes turned feral. She launched herself at Naandril II's Warpgate facility, which had already begun to activate and form a portal to the homeworld. Before it could do so, she erupted into the containment room and unleashed a storm of psionic power, obliterating hundreds of personnel inside at the atomic level. Their minds screamed in alarm for but an instant before a wave of Primal Psionics buffeted their bodies, shredding them into a fine, bloody mist.

With nobody to manipulate the Warpgate, it collapsed. Demila didn't wait even a second before launching toward the cables that powered it, ripping them apart so no reinforcements could force open a connection from the other side.

Then, she snapped her head toward the soul containment facility. Already, a pair of 7th Level Psions were on their way to intercept her.

[Demila!] A male Psion roared in the distance, his voice projecting through millions of tons of the planet's soil. [Stand down and give up now if you still have a shred of the Founder's Wills left in you! Otherwise, you shall die today!]

[Is that so?] Demila asked, confidence oozing from her pores. [Perhaps. But not to the likes of YOU!]

Two Psions smashed through the ceiling of the Warpgate Nexus. They rushed at Demila, but she flickered to the side and waved her hands. Instantly, psionic clones of herself rushed out in all directions, surrounding her two attackers.

While this might be a Psion Soul World, it actually had very few able-bodied high ranking Psions to protect it. The majority of its security forces were only at the 6th Level, and these two 7th Level Psions were considered more than sufficient for deterring enemy threats long enough for reinforcements to arrive. Never did they imagine a member of their own kind who knew the location of the Warpgate would arrive and cut off reinforcements before they could arrive!

Demila roared savagely. Her eyes stretched sideways in the Volgrim equivalent of a maniacal grin as her psionic duplicates started brutally pummeling her fellow 7th Level Psions. The male was primarily a Body Enhancer, while the female was a Psyker capable of debilitating powerful foes by attacking their minds directly. At the same time, she was extremely talented in Primal Psionics, making her capable of fighting with raw telekinetic power.

Unfortunately, her Psyker powers meant nothing to a high-level telepath like Demila, someone who possessed nearly impenetrable mental shields. It turned out her control of Primal Psionics was also grossly inferior to Demila as well!

Demila was not weak. She was over a million years old. She was born only an era or two after the end of the Great Wars. She might not be in the same age category as the Founders, but she wasn't that much younger, comparatively. She had tried to ascend to the level of Executor for countless millennia, but even though she failed to do so, she did *not* stop honing her fighting skills.

Demila casually revealed one high level Psionic ability after another. Aside from Body Enhancements, she had mastered nearly every other discipline to some degree, which had also caused her Psionic Core to become brittle. No Psion could master every art, and this was in fact the reason she had failed to advance.

But it made her unbeatable when facing other 7th Level Psions!

Demila conjured massive psionic fists to smash and pummel her two opponents. She sent the male flying, pulverizing him into the dirt before grabbing and squeezing her

female adversary with brutal force. Her opponents screamed in pain, but broke free and repeatedly attacked her again and again!

[YOU WILL NOT WIN!] The male Psion shouted, forming his very words into a weapon. He speared that weapon toward Demila's forehead, but she batted it aside with ease. [YOU ARE A TRAITOR TO THE VOLGRIM EMPIRE!]

[The Empire betrayed me a long time ago.] Demila countered.

Boom!

The male Psion crashed into Demila, throwing his entire body at her and tanking any of her counter hits. When he raised his fist to smash her skull into meat and bone paste, he was shocked to see her body disappear, turning into particles of light.

Suddenly, his eyes flashed with realization.

[Kamira!! We've been tricked! Demila, she's- AAARGH!]

The male Psion's body abruptly shuddered with a terrible, soul-racking pain. His muscles spasmed and his bones trembled. Tears fell from his eyes as he felt his life force rapidly beginning to dwindle. With the last bit of his strength, he turned to peer through the planet, looking upon the container where his soul was housed.

Demila was there. She held his soul in her hands and greedily sucked up its power, vacuuming the full psionic knowledge of her enemy with reckless abandon. In an instant, countless fragments of knowledge, countless insights, countless inspirations washed across her soul, making her pupils dilate with hunger.

This was the power of devouring! This was a power which formerly belonged only to demons!

[HAHAHAHA!!!] Demila cackled evilly, as she felt the life ebb from her opponent's body. [Little Harido, you were fooled too easily! The young should always fear the old!!]

The female Psion, Kamira, reacted with horror. [Harido, no! Demila, you monster!!]

She triangulated Demila's position and charged through the facility, smashing down walls in her race to save her companion and soul-mate. But before she could reach Demila, her power also started to fade away. Kamira shuddered violently as Demila revealed the second soul held in her palms and started greedily sucking it down like a human slurping spaghetti noodles. Kamira lost control of her body and struck the ground, rolling to a stop as she lost consciousness.

Demila laughed. She couldn't believe how easy it was to fool these two stupid juniors! All she had to do was hide her presence for only a few seconds and lead them along with a psionic copy while her real body located their souls. After that, it was mere child's play!

[HA HA HA HAAA!!! THE WEAK SHOULD FEAR THE STRONG! THE YOUNG SHOULD FEAR THE OLD! THE STUPID SHOULD FEAR THE WISE! This begins my ascension! The rise of the Great Demila!!]

Demila did not fully devour the souls of her juniors. She drained them down to the level of Initiator, then casually tossed their souls back into the containers that previously housed them. Even if she wanted to devour them, for some reason, she couldn't. Perhaps it was because the power of devouring primarily belonged to the demons, but Demila found that she had to leave their Psionic Cores intact. She could absorb their powers and copy their knowledge, but she could not drain them entirely.

Of course, she could crush their cores and kill them, but she didn't hold any genuine animosity towards these two juniors. She only desired their power, knowledge, and insights. Once their threat was neutered, they were of no concern to her.

Killing them would also go against her long-term plans. What good was power if she didn't have a future Empire of subjects to fear and respect her?!

Demila grinned with her eyes. Her hunger grew more intense after experiencing the baptism of power associated with draining the cores of Kamira and Harido.

[More. I NEED MORE.]

Without hesitation, and knowing reinforcements would eventually arrive, Demila began crazily grabbing every powerful Psion soul in the vicinity. 5th Level, 6th Level, even 7th Level souls all became weakened and useless as she hungrily gobbled up their power, sucking down their vitality until there was almost nothing left.

All across the Volgrim Empire, countless Psions screamed in pain and begged for mercy as their life forces fell to ruin. Centuries, millennia, even eons of accumulation fell to dust as Demila sucked them all dry, empowering herself without caring about the total cost to the entire Empire.

Demila's body inflated with power. All at once, a rushing of energy slammed into her Psionic Core. She lifted her head and roared to the heavens as it finally happened.

After a million years, she broke through! Demila conquered the 7th Level and became the newest Executor to smash the wall that previously held her at bay. She laughed maniacally, grinning like a feral beast before continuing her rampage.

By the time reinforcements arrived, it would be too late. She would have already eaten every decent soul on Naandril II.

Suddenly, her gaze froze. Demila finally spotted what she had been looking for from the beginning.

Sequestered in a secret part of the facility, two Psionic souls burned brighter than all the rest. These were no ordinary souls… they belonged to a pair of… Executors!

Her eyes turned blood red.

[EXECUTOR RILEY. EXECUTOR VI. ALL THESE MILLENNIA… YOU LAUGHED AT ME. BUT YOU WILL LAUGH NO MORE.]

[**YOU WILL NEVER MOCK ME AGAIN! HAHAHAHAAAA!!!**]

Somewhere in the Milky Way, the two Executors shivered in terror. A cold sense of dread washed over them.

Before they could understand what was causing them to feel such fear, the light left their eyes.

Vi, flying across Volgarius's upper atmosphere toward the Warpgate Nexus, lost all control of her body. Her deceased form hurtled from the sky, flew into a stratoscraper, and exploded into chunks of meat as her meteoric crash brought ruin to her flesh, muscles, and bones.

Riley was flying through the Void when she perished. Her body lost control and fell from hyperspace, causing her to drift into a pitch-black region of the Void where it would never again be found.

In a single day, the Volgrim Empire lost more than it had in tens of millennia before.

This was only the beginning of its Total Rendition…

Part 643: Myriad Escape!

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. In a hidden dimension...

Inside a secret location, tucked away from the outside universe, a creature trembled in pain. Its body was curled together, painfully lashed into place, its bones wrapped around each other like a ball of yarn. It could not move more than a millimeter in any direction. An orb of psionic energy enveloped its body, holding it unmoving in place and preventing it from escaping.

This entity was none other than the Myriad Deity: Mephisto.

Mephisto's head was forced between his knees and legs, his arms wrapped over top and held tight by Founder Dosena's psionic power. As a Bottom Level Cosmic, he had no ability to resist the full power of a Middle Cosmic. The only reason he was not dead was because Dosena had not yet found a way to kill him. Her power, though horrifying, only came up equal to the defensive strength of his dragonbone body. Having stolen these bones from the corpse of the ancient dragon, Leviathan, Mephisto's hardiness was unfathomable. Only a superior High Cosmic or Apex Cosmic, such as the angel named Anaelle, who was summoned by Bael to the material plane, would be capable of breaking his bones and eradicating his existence.

However, the patchwork nature of Mephisto's soul provided him with a terrible weakness. If Dosena were to assault him for long enough, she might be able to eradicate Mephisto and the other Emperors comprising his soul, killing them all and retaining the dragon bones for the Volgrim Empire's own usage. In fact, that was her ultimate plan.

But now, as Mephisto snarled to himself like he had been doing ever since being imprisoned in this secret place, unable to perceive the world around himself, he noticed with delight that his prison's bonds had begun to weaken. Mephisto did not know why its power had faded, but he sensed a huge secret!

[Where isss Dosssena?] Mephisto hissed inside his Mind Realm. [Isss she toying with usss? Or perhapsss...?]

Zamiel was the first to respond. [She might have left for a while. If she travels far enough away, we might be able to break out and escape!]

[Or not.] Emperor Lupus countered lazily. [It could be a trap to toy with us and break our spirit. Not that mine *isn't* already.]

[We must not give up.] Emperor Yama said, his tone boiling with hatred. [We will not allow a mere *female* to pin us down! We must fight! We must break FREE!]

Lupus may have mentally given up on escaping, but the other three core Emperors did not. As a result, through the efforts of Mephisto, Zamiel, and Yama, the dragon's body began to twitch and shudder. They forced demonic energy outward, trying to brute-force a gap in their encirclement. Anything to break the stalemate!

"RRRRGH!"

The dragon's mouth twitched, and a pained grunt roared from its throat.

The psionic orb encasing them, pinning and binding them in place, flexed ever so slightly.

[COME ON!] Zamiel shouted. [FIGHT, YOU LAZY BASTARDS! I DON'T WANNA BE STUCK IN THIS SHITHOLE FOR THE REST OF ETERNITY!]

[Break free! Essscape!] Mephisto hissed.

[Push! Push, dammit!!] Yama added.

[Whatever.] Lupus grunted, her soul rolling its eyes.

The psionic prison flexed outward for a moment, allowing the dragon to slightly move its right arm away from its head. But then it pressed back against the Myriad Deity's body, sealing it in a newer, more painful position.

Like this, minutes became hours. The Myriad Deity became emboldened. With Dosena seemingly allowing it to make progress, it fought harder and harder, writhing around with its whole body, feeling its psionic prison grow weaker and weaker all the time.

Eventually, Mephisto and the others managed to pull their head out of their legs and press their palms together before their chest. They still could not see past the barrier engulfing them, but it had weakened enough that it no longer pressed on them as heavily. They could much more easily adjust position. And so, they summoned all their demonic energy into their grasp and roared with hatred.

"BREAK FOR USSS!!!"

Their Cosmic power might be qualitatively low, but the sheer amount of demonic power taken from all the Emperors they had devoured made them quantitatively formidable! All at once, the souls of those Emperors obediently released all their energy, and the dragon momentarily exploded with enough power to rip apart the psionic prison and leap out before it could close up and seal it once more.

Mephisto was free!!

He barely took a moment to revel in his freedom and exhaustion before freezing in place and quickly assessing his surroundings.

None of the demons had a clue where they were. When they stretched out their senses, they only managed to ascertain they were no longer in the Milky Way itself. Somehow, they had ended up in a small sub-dimension, no larger than a small town. It had many levels, extending up, down, forward, backward, left and right. It seemed to be some sort of compound area with room for all sorts of strange Volgrim experiments.

In Mephisto's prison chamber, he saw the central area where he had been held. All sorts of mystical chains lashed onto the psionic prison that had previously held him. These chains glowed with the power of a Middle Cosmic and held fast to the walls. With his meager strength, he had no chance of breaking them. Even his dragon bones wouldn't help! He quickly realized he had only escaped because some of the chains had wiggled out of place due to his movements, opening a gap at the top for him to escape through.

The chains attached to statues along the walls, and the corners of the prison. These statues all appeared to be of High Psions. None of the Myriad Deity's soul recognized them. Some were male, some female, and a few were ambiguous in gender. Not that the demons particularly cared.

[We need to get the hell out of here before Dosena returns.] Zamiel said. [I doubt she'll make our cell as 'comfortable' the second time around.]

None of the others objected.

[A sssound idea.] Mephisto said slowly. [But... the lawsss of ssspaccce ssseem to be ssstrange here.]

Yama looked around suspiciously. [We're too deep inside this construct's nexus. Let's head toward the edges. Maybe we can break out once we're there.]

Lupus frowned. Unlike the others, she sensed something ominous in the air. A feeling that the Myriad Deity was being... observed. But it was a light sensation. She couldn't tell what direction that feeling came from.

After contemplating their situation for but a few moments, the Myriad Deity's members formed a consensus. The dragon exploded into motion, rushing toward the prison's exit and kicking the door open with ease! Clearly, Dosena did not think the dragon would be able to escape its psionic restraints, so she didn't bother forming the walls and door of anything particularly sturdy.

The dragon charged out of the small prison and arrived in an inner building, pausing to look around. The prison itself consisted of only a single cell, and it had been assembled in the heart of this dimension to hold Mephisto specifically. There were no other prisoners that he could sense. As for the room the cell was built within, it resembled a human church, with murals, paintings, stained glass windows allowing in artificial light, and other strangely holy and religious icons that seemed incongruent with the Dosena he knew. Then again, none of the Emperors really had any idea who the Second Founder was. They certainly hadn't even spoken to her, aside from when she captured them.

"Where isss thisss...?" The Myriad Deity wondered out loud.

[If I had to guess... I'd assume it's Founder Dosena's Secret Sanctum.] Lupus commented dryly. [It's her personal area. If you really want to piss her off, you could smash her stuff. But you're probably better off escaping before she returns.]

The thought of sending that cocky bitch of a Psion into a rage actually made Mephisto and the other male Emperors pause for a moment. But since they had no idea *if* or *when* she would return, they decided not to take any risks. They rushed toward the direction they sensed was the edge of the Sanctum, broke through the doors of her Holy Cathedral, and arrived in a courtyard filled with strange trees.

Mephisto blinked. He couldn't believe his eyes! These trees resembled, to some degree, the strange gem-trees he had observed in the Cosmic Realm! Psionic Fruits grew on their branches, possessing some sort of innate power he couldn't quite decipher. He was immediately tempted to eat one... or perhaps a thousand... but he wasn't certain if there would be any incompatibilities with his demonic powers. And besides! He was in a rush! He had to escape!

Mephisto looked into the distance. He saw a massive ethereal 'wall'. It was not a wall of brick and stone, or steel, but a wall of Void itself. A barrier sealing the Sanctum from the outer cosmos.

That was the way out!

Mephisto rushed at the wall! He tore at it with his claws and attempted to rip it apart, but to his shock he found that it was stronger than a Middle Cosmic. This wall was not sealed or empowered by a Cosmic's energy, but by the laws of the universe itself!

[No, no nonono!] Mephisto shouted. [Thisss isss the way out! It mussst be! Why can't we break through?!]

[Our knowledge of spatial laws are laughable.] Yama said, analyzing the situation careful. [Hehehe. That bitch really did us dirty.]

[Don't we have Warper souls at our disposal?] Zamiel asked. [Let's try using those!]

The other souls came to a consensus. They quickly tapped into the power of Warpers and tried to open a portal back to the outer universe.

But they failed!

The portal only phased into existence for a millisecond before sputtering and dying. They tried again, and again, and again... but each time, they failed.

"Dammit, dammit, dammit!!" The Myriad Deity roared, a collective wail of anger from all its composite souls. "Not fair! Thisss isss not fair! We have to break free!"

Suddenly, the dragon fell silent. It looked around, feeling that *something* had fixated its gaze upon an unwanted intruder.

Mephisto swiveled the dragon's body around. He went on the alert, his cold, undead heart turning more frigid than ever.

"Who... who's there?!"

Deep within the Sanctum, at its lowest level, a trickle of power wormed its way from an unknown holding chamber. That power wafted through the various hallways, then dove through the soil of the Sanctum before suspending itself mere inches from the dragon's face.

It took the appearance of a single blackened finger.

[**INVADER.**] A voice spoke, its tone full of malice and vigilance. [**YOU… ARE NOT WELCOME HERE.**]

If Mephisto still had any body hair, all of it would have been standing on end. The power dripping off this singular finger was unfathomable. Horrifying! It went way beyond the realm of Middle Cosmic! Just what the hell was it, and why was it living within the Volgrim Empire's confines?! Did Unarin even know about it??

"No, not invaders!" Mephisto screeched in fear. "Let us out! We're here by mistake! We- UGHH!!"

The tiny tendril of energy struck Mephisto with violent force. It pounded the Myriad Deity against the spatial wall with so much power that the rib bone it struck immediately cracked! The Myriad Deity's souls all shuddered and lost cohesion for an instant before reforming back into one.

[Spawn of a broodmother!] Lupus shouted, no longer as distant as before. She suffered the same pain as the rest. She might rather be dead than part of the Myriad Deity's monstrous form, but the pain from that one hit instantly woke her out of her stupor. She sure as hell didn't want to die to this ancient horror!

When the creature sent another tiny attack at the Myriad Deity, the dragon instantly dove to the side, evading the attack. The 'finger' of the monster struck the spatial wall, and the entire Sanctum rumbled! The spatial wall cracked slightly, and the Emperors quickly looked toward that crack.

[Chanccce!!] Mephisto shouted.

With every bit of the Myriad Deity's strength, Mephisto and the rest flapped their wings and rushed at the spatial crack, roaring with all their might as they smashed into it before it could reform. They pounded through it and flew into a Void of the Unknown, with no stars or spatial anomalies visible anywhere. Instantly, the Sanctum began pulling away from them, turning into a speck in the distance as they lost control of their bodies, and spatial storms buffeted their figures.

"AAAAHH!!"

The dragon roared in pain. The Sanctum slowly disappeared, and the unknown horror that attacked them did not give chase, evidently content with the 'invaders' leaving of their own accord.

Seconds later, the voidspace around them abruptly brightened. They fell out of the other dimension and tumbled back into Realspace, less than 100,000 miles away from Volgarius itself!

The Myriad Deity instantly ceased its tumbling with a flap of its wings. Its composite souls went on the alert, quickly sensing hundreds of thousands of powerful Volgrim ships in the area. Sensor beams locked onto their location. Across the bridges of many naval warships, commanders and captains shouted orders as they not only dealt with the Psion Collapse Crisis, but a sudden and unexpected new crisis. The arrival of... a dragon made of bone?!

It took nearly no time at all for the information to relay to the Founders. Unarin's brother, Randis, monitored the communication channels and immediately noticed the anomaly. His pupils shrunk to pinpricks. Without hesitation, he issued an order.

"That's Demon Deity Mephisto! He has escaped the Second Founder's prison! She is currently out of commission. I will send Executor Nufaris to intervene. In the meantime, attack that demon at once! Do not let him make landfall on Volgarius!"

Hardly had a minute passed in realspace time while Mephisto quickly swept his Cosmic senses outward, determined Dosena was nowhere in the star system that he could sense, and that only one Executor was in the region, capable of threatening him, before countless starship weapons suddenly fired at him.

Missiles, bombs, beams, phasers, and lasers all blasted Mephisto in unison, raking his body and forcing him backward. The Myriad Deity grunted as blinding lights struck his body with enough force to blow up planetary settlements, yet left not a single mark on his pristine bones!

"**RRRGH! You little SSSHITSSS!**" Mephisto roared, his Cosmic Voice booming throughout the vacuum of the Void.

His fury exploded. How dare these insignificant worms attack him?! He flapped his wings and launched himself at the nearest capital ship, the VLL Melkia IV, tearing into it with his claws and piercing through its mortal-grade shields with ease. As a Bottom Cosmic, he possessed power aplenty. Mere mortal weapons and armor were no barrier to him!

4th, 5th, and 6th Level Psions launched from some of the ships. Unfortunately, thanks to Demila's rampage elsewhere in the Milky way, a full third of all Psions had been

completely debilitated. Their numbers weren't the only thing reduced, but their morale as well. They had no way of fighting back! Her cowardly attack left them totally vulnerable to this rampaging monster! Even worse, early reports stated Executor Vi had fallen, and Riley might have joined her!

These young and weak Psions were, therefore, not eager to fight a rampaging Bottom Cosmic. Only the 6th Level Psions had a fighting chance; the others knew they were little more than cannon fodder. They only hoped to try and slow Mephisto down until Nufaris could circle the planet and arrive on scene.

Mephisto blasted apart the VLL Melkia IV with contemptuous ease. He roared with delight at finally being given a way of letting out his rage. These Volgrim DARED cage the mighty Myriad Deity, so they would suffer immeasurably! As a Bottom Cosmic, the lowest of the low, a creature barely a single step above the mortal level, he suffered essentially no Akashic Backlash from his actions. He could slaughter, he could murder, and he could kill to his heart's delight!

"**HAHAHAHA!**" Mephisto laughed, his voice booming throughout the void. "**You insssectsss will RUE the day you sssaw fit to imprissson thisss gloriousss Deity! Kekekeke!!**"

The young Psions roared with hatred and rage. This mud-dweller intended to wreak havoc on the same day as the Great Traitor?! They must be in cahoots!

Unable to intervene in Demila's atrocity, they instead took out their rage on Mephisto. Chains of psionic energy lashed around his arms and legs by the hundreds. Thunderbolts fired at him and exploded against his body. Space twisted and turned to stymie his movements.

But Mephisto merely laughed! These paltry and weak Psions were no challenge for the lauded Myriad Deity! They slowed him down for a moment or two, but he broke free of their restraints, laughing at how much weaker they were compared to Dosena's. He lunged at the strongest 6th Level Psions and reaped their lives like wheat, ripping them to pieces. Most frighteningly, he devoured their souls! He did not allow their soul energies to return to the worlds of Naandril I, II, or III. The Psions killed by Mephisto became one with him, empowering him, never again returning to serve their glorious Empire.

Tears of hatred and rage poured from the faces of the even weaker Psions. They were but meat on the chopping block. They had no chance against him!

From the distance, a beacon of power rocketed around the edge of the planet's atmosphere. It raced toward Mephisto at superliminal speeds, weaving between the starships in orbit deftly.

It was Executor Nufaris!

[YOU FILTHY DEMON! UNHAND MY SUBORDINATES!]

Nufaris was enraged. He was well and truly pissed. Never did he imagine Demila would fall to the whims of the demons. Never did he imagine she would betray the Psions in such a profound way at the same time as Mephisto escaped the Second Founder's prison. He wasn't entirely certain, but all of this smelled of a conspiracy. The two must be working together!

If he wasn't allowed to leave Volgarius and intercept Demila, then by goddamn, he would at least unleash his rage upon the next best enemy!

Mephisto sneered. Less than thirty seconds had passed since the start of his rampage, yet Nufaris would arrive within only a few more. If it weren't for him taking care not to smash through the Volgrim armada in his path, he would have arrived fifteen seconds earlier. He might have saved dozens of younger Psions!

"**A mere Executor daresss to battle thisss Deity?**" Mephisto asked derisively. "**You lack the qualificationsss!**"

Nufaris punched his fists together. He rocketed toward Mephisto without stopping, conjuring a shield of spatial energy around himself as he flew directly at his hated draconic enemy.

[WE SHALL SEE ABOUT THAT!]

Boom!

Nufaris slammed into Mephisto and started driving him forward, pushing him further and further from Volgarius, eventually breaking the armada's encirclement as the two of them rushed further out into the more sparsely populated Void!

"Gah!" Mephisto roared. He snapped his head down and bit onto the spatial shield, then yanked himself away, allowing Nufaris to flicker off into the distance for a moment before swooping around for a second attack run.

Nufaris aimed his palm outward. A giant hand made of spatial energies formed around himself, then launched at Mephisto.

[I do not know how you escaped Founder Dosena's prison, but it won't be long before I put you back there myself!]

Mephisto grinned. He still couldn't sense Dosena's presence, and the fact this snarky little bastard thought himself her equal was hysterical. Perhaps Dosena was more indisposed than he previously thought?

"Come at usss then! We do not fear a fight with a weak Cosssmic like you!"

Their battle would decide the fate of Volgarius.

Part 644: Mephisto's Massacre

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. Volgarius's Orbit.

Space warped and deformed around Nufaris. He rushed at Mephisto not with the intent to kill, but a need to lock him down, trap him, and eventually re-imprison him. Nufaris knew from a secret discussion with Dosena that Mephisto's body was too durable for him to break. The only way to kill Mephisto would be by destroying his much weaker unified Emperor souls. Not only were they a critical vulnerability, but doing so would give the Volgrim Empire a massive amount of Living Moldanium! This could offer them a huge buffer of powerful alloys to be used for making weapons and armor!

Just when it seemed Nufaris would collide with Mephisto, the dragon clapped his palms together, then yanked them apart, summoning his most well known and highly effective ability...

"**DARK MISSST!**"

A hellish wall of black fog expanded outward in a massive sphere. It instantly shut down all visual-based sensor and camera systems, countless forms of LIDAR and other highly advanced scanning systems, and so much more! The expanding wall of darkness didn't only expand outward in a plain sphere though; Mephisto deliberately curved its trajectory in an oval shape, bending it toward the Volgrim armada.

Within seconds, countless ships at the periphery of the fleet, closer to the planet than Mephisto's current coordinates, became engulfed by the oppressive realm of shadow. Transmissions from these ships abruptly fell silent. Their sister vessels lost contact, and their fates became uncertain.

Using only his cosmic senses, Nufaris managed to triangulate Mephisto's general position, but he found that his other senses simply couldn't lock on to the wiley dragon anymore. Mephisto cleverly turned his body partially intangible and reduced the 'glow' of his already rather pitiful Cosmic Aura, causing him to become even stealthier than before.

Nufaris charged at the spot where he sensed Mephisto, but his prepared spatial attack attack whiffed, striking the emptiness of space and flying off into the void. His void-chains, intended to begin the process of binding Mephisto, instead became like a clown's antics. He quickly spun around, trying desperately to sense Mephisto's movements.

"**Kekekeke!**" Mephisto gurgled, his shrill laughter erupting from multiple places within the fog. "**What an embarrasssing disssplay, Nufarisss! Where are you aiming? We're over here, you fool!**"

Nufaris frowned. He sensed a flicker of danger from his right. He instantly pivoted to face it, only for a shadowy specter of a dragon to charge at him. It wasn't Mephisto, but rather one of his weak shadow-clones.

[Mere tricks!] Nufaris scoffed. He sent a beam of spatial energy out and fired it into the core of the shadow dragon, bursting it like a balloon. But then, for some reason, Mephisto fell completely silent.

Nufaris tensed up. He looked around, waiting for another attack, but it didn't come. The Dark Mist started to retreat, then it vanished completely, regurgitating Nufaris back into realspace. At that moment, a fellow Psion, one of the surviving 5th Level juniors among the fleet, finally managed to transmit a psio-burst to his lauded Executor.

[Executor Nufaris! It was a trick! He's moving toward Volgarius! Hurry, we can't stop him!!]

Nufaris's heart turned cold. He realized he'd been had. Mephisto never had any intention to fight him. That son of a bitch was no Psion. He knew nothing of honor. Three of his souls belonged to Mephisto, Yama, and Zamiel. They were pure scum, even among demons. They would always fight dirty before fighting fair.

[No! NO!] Nufaris roared, as he locked on to the Cosmic energy signal racing toward Volgarius. [Don't you DARE!]

Nufaris conjured the full power of an Executor and launched himself toward Volgarius. He was faster than Mephisto, and not by a little. Unfortunately, he could not match up to the vile dragon in one regard... Mephisto had no qualms about killing any mortals in his path!

Mephisto callously smashed through ship after ship, deliberately causing as much damage as possible while treating these previously high-and-mighty vessels as toys made of wet tissue paper. Neither shields nor formidable alloys could compare to even this bottom-level Cosmic comprised of high-level dragonbones.

But while Mephisto could completely ignore the weak, faint stings of an Akashic Backlash most pitiful, Nufaris did not have such a luxury. He had to dodge, side-slip, and

teleport around many destroyed vessels, taking care not to accidentally kill any mortals while pursuing his hated foe. He did not only do this because of the Akashic Backlash, but also because... these were his fellow Volgrim! What sort of figurehead would he be if he caused his own people harm? He had to preserve as many lives as possible, especially while that filthy Demila was wreaking havoc.

Thus, Mephisto managed to keep ahead of Nufaris. He drew closer and closer to Volgarius, sometimes even slowing down a little to smash through a particularly juicy capital-class ship in his path. He sneered whenever he noticed Nufaris momentarily slowing down to dodge some debris or try not to hurt any minuscule mortals.

Another psio-burst reached Nufaris's mind, making his body shudder upon hearing the bad news.

[Executor! Demila has appeared at Naandril I! She's slaughtering even more Psions! What should we do?! Our souls are there! If this keeps up-]

The voice abruptly went inert. That Psion fell silent as he lost connection with his soul. Demila had struck again.

[Dammit, dammit, dammit!] Nufaris roared.

He had never experienced this level of rage, this feeling of helplessness, this pitiful level of despair. Never in all his years! His Empire was collapsing, he was the only one powerful enough to put up a fight against its dark fate, but his power... simply wasn't enough.

Mephisto finally struck Volgarius's upper atmosphere. His body ignited with flames as he hurtled toward the stratoscrapers below, burning up in re-entry yet suffering no physical damage. His arrival send out shockwaves that blasted apart countless windows, deafened millions of Volgrim at the ground level, and blew out the eardrums of those nearest the sky.

"It'sss time to have a little FUN!" Mephisto shouted while laughing evilly.

Unlike Mephisto, Nufaris's atmospheric entry was much less explosive. He flitted between the air molecules, separating them with his psionic powers so as to not cause immense damage to the Volgrim below. Unfortunately, what he saw when he arrived left his heart metaphorically bleeding with pain. Mephisto had deliberately crashed his body into the largest stratoscraper. He tore it to shreds, atomizing it with nothing more than

the raw weight and durability of his dragon bones. Hundreds of thousands of Low Psions, Technopaths, and Changelings inside the tower fell silent as their bodies were shredded into flecks of meat and speckles of bone. Millions of tons of glass, composited steel, and other materials collapsed into the stratoscraper's footprint, spreading out and causing extreme damage to other adjacent towers.

This in turn weakened their foundations. Two nearby ones immediately began to topple over, which Nufaris belatedly realized could cause a horrifying domino effect. Even if Mephisto did nothing else, the Stratoscrapers would continue to fall over, slam into their neighboring towers, then force those to fall sideways as well. Hundreds of millions, if not billions of Volgrim would perish within the hour!

Naturally, Mephisto realized this too. He sent a gleaming red gaze back at his pursuer, cackling shrilly. "Kekeke! What now, Nufarisss?! Going to let all thessse pretty little mortalsss die?! Don't worry, we'll caussse even more havoc... over here!"

He rushed to the west and slammed his body into a different stratoscraper, this time deliberately aiming to send it toppling sideways. Nufaris tried to charge in and stop him, but the vicious demon simply lunged downward into the collapsing debris, shielding himself with the dying bodies of tens of thousands of puny mortals.

Nufaris, unable to stop the demon directly, instead tried to stabilize the situation. He reached out with his powers and slowed the fall of a hundred stratoscrapers, preventing them from toppling over into other adjacent towers... but this proved to be another mistake! Mephisto simply continued racing off into the distance, ripping apart one tower after the next, causing ten, a hundred, even a thousand to blast into pieces and fall west, east, north, and south as well.

The devastation was incalculable. The loss of life immense! 5th and 6th Level Psions, what few remained, quickly rose up to try and stop the cascading domino effects and to free up their Executor to pursue the dragon, but their numbers were too few, and many of them were rapidly dying off due to Demila's unseen antics elsewhere in the galaxy.

Nufaris felt a chill go down his spine.

This was no longer merely the collapse of the Psions. It was the genocide of his Empire.

How many friends would die today? How many brothers? Sisters? How many famous researchers, historians, and travelers? How many inventors, warlords, and geniuses were

about to be snuffed out?

No.

He couldn't let this be.

He couldn't let it all come to an end!

Nufaris's eyes filled with tears. Rage swelled in his heart. He abruptly launched himself toward Mephisto like a railgun shell. Mephisto jolted in surprise when Nufaris slammed into a collapsing stratoscraper, pounded through every mortal in his path, and crazily chased Mephisto with no more regard for anything but his foe.

[YOU WILL DIE TODAY, DEMON. YOU WILL DIE!!]

Akashic Backlashes struck Nufaris, causing him innumerable injuries. His eyes turned bloodshot as he felt pieces of his Psionic Core breaking apart. But it didn't matter. He wouldn't allow this fiend to kill any more Volgrim. He had to stop the Empire's bleeding.

No matter the cost!

Mephisto hurriedly started to conjure another orb of Dark Mist in his palm, but Nufaris slammed into him, lashed his body to Mephisto's spine, and wrapped both of them with chains of Spatial energy.

[YOUR EVIL WAYS END HERE!]

Mindlessly, like a crazed animal, Nufaris launched himself skyward, dragging the demon along. He didn't care what it took anymore. He didn't care what price he would have to pay. What good were honor and glory when his species' survival was at stake?!

It was the law of the jungle now. Kill or be killed! And Nufaris would not allow this wretched dragon to cause any further harm.

Mephisto fought madly. He couldn't believe how abruptly Nufaris had changed strategies. It was like a switch flipped in his brain! The dragon struggled and tried to break free of the spatial chains wrapping him, but for every chain he broke, two more took their place.

If it were before, Nufaris could have kept this up practically forever. A weak little Bottom Cosmic was no match for a Low Cosmic nearing the next level. But that was before Nufaris buffeted his body, soul, and Psionic Seed with Akashic Backlashes. The

grief of killing his fellow Volgrim, even if they would have died instants later, also rocked his emotions.

He hated Mephisto.

He hated himself!

He hated how weak he was, despite attaining a level of power that would make his lessers treat him like a god.

Nufaris shot out of Volgarius's atmosphere and rushed past the armada. A brief Psio-burst entered his mind...

[Divinator Fellrun has engaged the traitor, Demila! They are battling at Naandril I!]

Nufaris barely registered the words. He was too overcome with grief to even think of how good this news was.

Fellrun was once considered the most powerful of the Executors. In terms of one-on-one combat, he was still unmatched. If he fought the traitor, he would surely win.

Nufaris pushed Mephisto out of the planet's orbit. He started burning his soul energy to initiate a transwarp activation, which launched himself and Mephisto out of the Volgarius star system at superliminal speeds!

"**Gah! Let usss go, you worthlesss worm! The mere ssstrugglesss of a dying Cosssmic! You are laughable! You cannot contain usss for long! When we break free, we will ssshatter your body, defile your corpssse, ssswallow your sssoul, forccce you to be one with usss, and ssserve usss for all eternity!**"

Nufaris ignored Mephisto. He had no energy to engage in conversation, not that he wanted to. He only had one desire now, in this critical time.

He needed to kill the dragon!

If it was before, he might have been able to if they had fought in honorable single combat. But Mephisto refused to play by the rules. That left Nufaris in such a pitiful condition that he also had to choose to break the rules.

Now, he could only think of one way to end this threat... permanently!

After traveling for less than a hundred lightyears, Nufaris fell out of warp and re-entered normalspace. He arrived inside a seemingly empty area of the Void, one where none would be able to observe him.

But Mephisto wasn't fooled. He instantly realized this area of space was not as empty as it seemed.

"**What are you doing?! YOU IMBECCCILE! You'll kill usss BOTH**!"

Nufaris's expression turned grim. He could already feel his soul starting to unravel.

Nufaris had a secret. It wasn't an especially well-kept one, but it was something the other Executors, as well as all the Founders knew.

He did not keep his True Soul inside one of the safe-worlds, like the other Executors did. In private, Dosena had confided in him that keeping his True Soul on his person was extremely risky. It meant he could die permanently if his body was ever slain.

But it also offered him a great benefit. He was able to rise through the ranks much more easily than the decidedly more timid Psions who opted to store their True Souls on one of the three worlds named Naandril. By keeping his True Soul on himself, he also ensured that if a traitor like Demila ran rampant, he wouldn't have to worry about dying without putting up a fight.

Unfortunately, it didn't matter anymore. He had suffered such a terrible Akashic Backlash that he was bound to fall back to the 7th Level… or worse.

Now, knowing that his life was soon to end, Nufaris pushed himself to his limits. In this very star system was his one hope for permanently killing this wretched creature.

A black hole!

Though it might not be as terrifying as the one at the center of the Milky Way, this particular black hole was still hundreds of times bigger than any red giant. It was supermassive, glowing with the white light it swallowed around its event horizon.

Mephisto struggled madly. He roared with draconic fury and tried to bend his head around to bite at Nufaris, but the Executor clamped Mephisto's mouth shut with another hastily conjured spatial chain.

[NOW… YOU WILL DIE HERE… DEMON! ALONG WITH ME!] Nufaris proclaimed.

"**No, no!**" Mephisto shouted, his 'voice' projecting through his muzzled jaws. "**You bassstard!!**"

Nufaris could not wait any longer. He would momentarily drop to the 7th Level and cease to be a threat to the dragon held tightly in his grasp. When that occurred, Mephisto

would surely break free, kill him, and return to Volgarius.

With his last burst of power, Nufaris launched himself and Mephisto into the event horizon. Their perception of time slowed to a crawl. Chaotic energies ripped at their souls, their bodies, their skin and bones. They screamed in agony, their voices silent, as the uncaring chaos of the universe ripped them asunder.

Moments later, the black hole swallowed them without leaving a single atom behind.

Nufaris, the savior of the Volgrim civilization, perished honorably, dragging an enemy that presented a species-ending threat to its demise.

Mephisto died screaming… like a squealing pig.

* * *

On the world of Volgarius, Founder Unarin stared up at the stars. He felt the weight of a planet momentarily fall upon his shoulders before fading away.

Dosena, held in his arms, coughed weakly. She opened her eyes, but was unable to move.

[Nu…Nufaris… he…]

"Dead." Unarin said sagely.

The First Founder closed his eyes. He bowed his head in solemn respect. Dosena once more fell unconscious.

The prodigy she cared so much about and had raised to become a future pillar of Volgrim society had fallen.

Now, it was a matter of debate whether or not the rest of the Volgrim would follow.

* * *

On the world of Grimvolas, a powerful lizard-like monster stood with his claws clasped behind his back. He gazed up at the stars, feeling a sensation not so dissimilar to what Unarin was experiencing.

He was Cinculu, the Fifth Founder, second in command of the Dolgrimites.

A female Dolgrimite, much larger and more imposing than he, stepped out onto that ridge and narrowed her eyes as she also seemed to see something beyond the mortal veil.

"Do you smell it, child? The winds of change."

"The blasphemers are finally paying the price for their wicked ways." Cinculu replied. "They denied their origins. They refused to see the light, to hear our sermons. They believed themselves undefeatable. Now, their technological terrors shall become their coffins."

"It would be amusing if it were not so *pathetic*." The Dolgrimite Matriarch spat. "Pah. Unarin, you useless fool of a 'First Founder.' How can one be so wise, yet so utterly incompetent? If only you had listened to our warnings, you might have averted the coming storm. But we shall not complain! The time is nigh. The rise of the True Volgrim will soon begin. Sinners and slaves to the machine will receive the punishment they deserve. Dolgris may be a fair and just God, but he is not merciful to nonbelievers."

"Dolgris guides us." Cinculu chanted, while closing his eyes and bowing his head. "His wisdom is boundless."

The Matriarch continued to stare up at the sky for a few moments longer before losing interest and turning away. She sneered to herself.

"How long before that timid little 'Plague' dares to make planetfall here, I wonder? How long before it learns the terror of Dolgris? The day is approaching. The War is unending."

* * *

On the world of Naandril I.

Demila levitated inside a large underground chamber. Her soul overflowed with power. She was solidly at the rank of Executor now, and rapidly approaching the final hurdle. If this kept up, she might even reach the same rank as the Second Founder.

Before her, another Psion also levitated. He was none other than Divinator Fellrun. The Master of Combat was well-known for his prowess in defeating singular foes.

[I won't lie, Demila. In my youth, I looked up to you.] Fellrun said, his voice calm. [You are one of the oldest of our kind. Yet now, I see that you are nothing more than a fossil who failed to advance her Seed. Desperate for a quick fix of easy power, you turned your back on your people and joined hands with the demons. You are irredeemable. You are garbage.]

Demila's face flickered with unknown emotions.

[I devoured Vi and Riley. When I arrived here, I also devoured Huron. But I haven't been able to locate *your* soul, Fellrun. Did you integrate it back into your body?]

[As soon as I figured out what you were doing, I did.] Fellrun admitted. [You will obtain no easy victory today, traitor.]

[That leaves only you, Sartran, and Nufaris, then.] Demila commented, as if tallying an unseen scoreboard. [Ah, but because of Beelzebub… no more Sartran. I hope you and Nufaris are enough to push me over the final plateau.]

[Even now, your soul drowns in sin.] Fellrun retorted. [All you think about is power. You are a greedy, self-serving, worthless excuse of a Psion. I am ashamed to have ever considered you my sister.]

Demila's expression darkened.

[What do you know, you petulant child?! What do you know of my struggles?! I fought for the Empire! I bled for it! Before you were even a gleam in the Creator's eye, I struggled to uplift myself through the power of Creation! I solidified my Seed, and then my progress came to a screeching halt! It was not fair! I did everything right!]

She continued to rant. [Besides, you aren't seeing the bigger picture! Once I become strong enough, the Volgrim Empire will have a new foundation of power to build upon! Not one, but two Middle Cosmics! Dosena can protect the homeworld, while I destroy the Plague right at their source. I can become the sword, while she becomes the shield. Don't you see?! This is all to win the war!]

Fellrun stared at Demila, momentarily dumbfounded.

[You… cannot possibly… believe in such a weak Truth.] Fellrun said, more disappointed than angry. [How can a Psion as ancient as you be hoodwinked by such an easily disproven lie? You are not creating a new pillar of power for our Empire… you are stripping away its foundation!]

[It doesn't matter how many Executors we have.] Demila retorted. [Only Middle, High, and Apex Cosmics can protect us from the Plague and other future Threats. I am not the blind one, Fellrun. You are! If other Psions were to do as I have done, we could devour these weak Sentients and strengthen ourselves, making our Empire indomitable!]

[You don't even believe the words you're speaking.] Fellrun bit back. [If you did, you would have eaten the humans and demons first. But *no*, you went after your fellow Psions

first. And why would you do that? Because you're a coward. You feared a fair fight against your fellow Psions.]

Fellrun lifted his chin. He looked down at Demila with all of his eyes, contempt dripping from his countenance.

[You are a coward, and you've always been one. That is the true reason your Seed stopped progressing. No amount of supplication, no amount of consulting the ancestors, no petitioning your betters would ever replace a heart of bravery. Becoming a High Psion isn't only an honor... it is a privilege... one you have *wasted*.]

Fellrun stretched out his arm and opened his palm. A two-headed glaive materialized in his grasp, formed out of hardened psionic energy, with an edge capable of cutting through all but the hardest alloys.

[What will it be then, *coward*?] Fellrun snarled. [Face me in honorable combat? Or flee into the void with your tail tucked between your legs? If you don't dare to fight me, then you have no right to refer to yourself as a 'future pillar of the Volgrim.']

Demila glared at her opponent with cold eyes.

[You have a lot of guts calling your senior a coward, brat. Not only will I fight you, but I will show you what two million cycles of experience have taught me!]

Fellrun readied himself for the fight of his life.

[I expect nothing but disappointment.]

Part 645: Demila's Delusions

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. Naandril I.

Creator Demila and Divinator Fellrun assessed each other for three seconds.

Then Fellrun attacked.

The younger of the two was still a million-ear-old monster. He did not wish to give his older opponent any time to think, and the fate of the Volgrim Empire hung in the balance. Instead of arrogantly taunting Demila as if he could not possibly lose, he assumed this was a life or death battle where no backup would come should he fail, and he was the last hope of the Psions to defeat her.

Neither Demila nor Fellrun knew of Executor Nufaris's fate, but that didn't matter. Nufaris was not allowed to leave Volgarius undefended, and all the other 8th Level Psions had fallen. If Fellrun could not beat Demila, then she would definitely move on to Naandril III and finish off the Psion population. The Volgrim Empire had lost two-thirds of its military might. Its future was already dire, but losing the rest would definitely seal its fate.

The male Psion whirled his two-headed glaive around his body. Jason Hiro might seem a master of the Bo Staff, but compared to Fellrun, he was like a child flailing his arms. Fellrun's movements were so efficient, so smooth and natural, that his conjured weapon felt as though it was simply something he was born with, like the tail of a crocodile, or the wings of an eagle.

He flickered across space and appeared before Demila in an instant, moving to behead her in one swift movement. She flickered to the side at the exact same time and dodged while summoning three swords that levitated around her. One of the swords slashed out and crashed against the glaive, deflecting its attack slightly. The other two cut and stabbed at Fellrun from tricky angles.

Fellrun allowed his glaive to bounce and reflect off Demila's first sword. He instantly reversed its momentum to snap the opposite side of the glaive at one of the swords stabbing toward his heart while also 'swimming' his feet upward in the air. His right foot casually kicked aside the final sword, breaking it to pieces and scattering its psionic

energy to the cosmos. It turned out he had summoned a barrier of psionic energy around his foot durable enough to counter the hardness of her sword.

In an instant, they traded three attacks, then two seconds later, they traded ten more! The two Psions moved with speed and ferocity. Fellrun pressed his offensive, but in truth he remained completely guarded, always paying attention to his opponent's movements.

[You may be a failure and a disgrace of a Psion unable to advance to the level of Executor on your own, but you are skilled in battle and a worthy opponent.] He spoke while fighting, easily able to multi-task during such a fast and brutal fight.

[And you are a fool if you think the reason I failed to advance was due to a lack of effort!] Demila snapped back, visibly irritated. [You are but a million cycles old, while I am two! I meditated, trained, learned from the ancestors, and did everything I possibly could! I am twice your age, you foolish boy! You will not leave here alive. I will swallow your power and advance to the next level!]

Demila flickered backward. She stopped focusing any attention on her swords. They, however, continued to attack Fellrun, albeit a little less effectively than before. This was because of her psionic specialty. As a 'Creator', she did not merely summon phantasms of psionic energy, but living, thinking constructs that had the capacity to fight and maneuver on their own. This ability had always been her secret weapon, her strongest trump card, but it had never been anywhere near as effective as it was after ascending to Executor. Now, her conjured weapons and constructs were much more intelligent, durable, and capable of fighting on their own than they were before!

Demila waved her hand. A copy of herself materialized to her right, and then another copy materialized on her left. The two of them shimmered along with her main body, and her soul signature blurred for a moment. When it stopped blurring, Fellrun narrowed his eyes.

He couldn't believe his psionic senses. Demila had clearly swapped places with one of her Psio-Clones, but he couldn't tell which one. All three of them had the same signature. They looked the same. They even moved the same!

[Impossible. No Psion can so casually create such vibrant living, breathing entities!] Fellrun exclaimed in disbelief.

[Just because I failed to advance my Seed does not mean I failed to advance my combat capabilities.] Demila said, this thought radiating out of each copy's head in

unison. [You are outmatched, *stupid child*.]

Demila could not defeat Fellrun if they fought on his terms. He was unbeatable in one-on-one combat. Fellrun had long established himself as capable of defeating foes much stronger than himself, so long as the battle only involved a duo. He was a Champion Killer. It was even rumored that if he fought the Second Founder, he could make her sweat, despite the power difference in their Seeds. But the equation changed when he fought many foes in unison. No longer was a victory as certain.

This had been proven many times during the Kolvaxian War. The Kolvaxians were once weak and pathetic, but Fellrun's ability to slaughter many weaker enemies was vastly inferior to other Executors. As a result, his notoriety fell. He was only dispatched to deal with Kolvax-Clones of the other Executors, as well as opponents worthy of his intervention.

Demila's three selves circled around Fellrun like vultures. One of them started rapidly firing powerful bursts of psionic lightning, striking barriers he instantly conjured. The other wielded metallic chains fitted with a razor-sharp tip at the end. She snapped the chain around like a whip, trying to entangle Fellrun's glaive and limbs to slow down his movements and create an opening. The final one manipulated space, making it much denser around Fellrun, and hampering him in tandem with the second one's efforts. All the while, they constantly summoned more and more swords to hamper and slow him down.

Fellrun snarled nastily. [These abilities are not yours, you witch! I know you! You are no master of Energy Manipulation!]

[I wasn't.] Demila admitted while smiling with her eyes. [But that was *before*. I see now a future path for the Volgrim! After I have taken up my rank as our species' newest 9th Level Psion, I will train the next generation of Psions to wield this power of the demons. The strong will climb the ladder of power! They will swallow those who are weaker and rapidly ascend, becoming unbeatable! Our numbers may thin, but our base of power will become indestructible. Quality over quantity!]

[Hah! You're one to speak of quality.] Fellrun sneered, batting away another dual sword-strike aimed at his vitals. [You're the lowest of our people, yet think yourself our messiah. We will not fall for your twisted ways, you mud-lover! Psions must remain pure!]

[Imbecile! Use your head!] Demila snapped back. [I am much older than you. I have seen more than you! Do you truly think it is a coincidence there is only one 9th Level Psion in our Empire? How can that be true when once, long ago, there were seven? Founder Dosena is manipulating all of you, feeding you lies to keep you down so she alone can act as our sole guardian. She hoards power because she does not trust us. As a result, we lacked high level champions who could attack and wipe away the Plague! We're losing the war because of her machinations!]

Fellrun could not offer a counter-argument. As it happened, he and the other Executors had privately discussed such a possibility many times. They were not stupid. They could sense that there was some sort of oddity preventing them from rising to the 9th Level. Dosena herself did not seem to be directly interfering, but something was definitely holding them all back. They simply did not know what.

Even so, Fellrun refused to accept the words of a so-called 'Executor' who had ascended through such a disgusting method as soul manipulation. Her words could not be trusted. She was likely being fed talking points by the demons!

[You will not corrupt my thoughts, mud-lover.] Fellrun said decisively. [Your lies fester like poison. Anyone who slanders our Founders deserves death!]

[You know I am right, yet you play at ignorance.] Demila countered. [Once I eliminate you, I will ensure the next Order of Psions does not contain such brainwashed fools.]

[There won't BE another Order!] Fellrun roared. [You have doomed our Empire! Two Middle Cosmics cannot protect all our star systems alone! The Plague already outnumbers us! Now you've ensured its total victory!!]

Fellrun couldn't be bothered to waste another word on his stupid senior. Even if there were grains of truth to what she said, he still forcibly shut off his critical thinking to focus on the fight.

His glaive abruptly changed form, catching Demila off-guard. It morphed from a hardened pole with two bladed ends to a pole with chains at each end attached to the blades. Its central region took on a plus-shape, and two additional chained heads sprouted, making it look like a helicopter of death.

This new weapon was cumbersome and unwieldy. Any amateur would probably injure or even kill themselves if they tried spinning it around just once, but Fellrun was no amateur. This was his ace in the hole.

He started whirling the four blades around himself as if they were nunchaku. He accelerated his speed and launched at one of Demila's bodies, the one firing lightning blasts, uncertain if it was her or not. At this point, he had to take a risk. He was supposed to be the attacker, but she held all the initiative by outnumbering him.

Fellrun focused his mind. When lightning bolts flew his way, he intercepted them with one of his nunchaku, absorbing the cosmic lightning in the blade and momentarily empowering it before snapping it at his opponent.

Slash-slash-slash!

Within three seconds, he cut down Demila's clone. He beheaded her, only to sense that a new clone had instantly taken the previous one's place and reappeared in the distance behind him alongside the others.

Fellrun rapidly calculated some attack vectors in his mind.

I fight with my body, while Demila fights with her psionic powers. Her energy expenditure will be much higher as a result. That means in a battle of attrition, she will exhaust herself much faster than me. If I keep forcing her to summon new clones and launch long-range attacks, she will eventually slow down. That's when I can end this... once and for all.

He turned and flew at the new Demila clone, as well as the other two. They split up and went in different ways, forcing him to pick one to follow. He frowned, unsure which one was the real one. They all felt exactly the same. He had no idea she possessed such an absurd duplication ability. This was not like Vulpanix, who could temporarily break the fabric of reality and conjure alternate versions of herself from other timelines. Demila's clones were made from pure psionic energy, yet their bodies were flesh and blood.

It broke all the rules he had come to learn regarding Psionic powers. How could she make such convincing duplicates?

A hint of disbelief entered his eyes. What if Demila was right? What if Dosena was holding her species back to enrich herself? What if there was more to a Psion's power than he knew? Maybe by linking up with the demons, Demila had tapped into a new power that could make them more formidable in the coming era?

No! That couldn't be right! She was a traitor and *had* to die.

Fellrun intensified his assault. He stepped on the air and started darting from left to right, charging after her clones much faster than before. Having assessed the situation, he realized that he could easily spare the energy expenditure, while she could not. In time, Demila would weaken faster and faster, make a mistake, and he could rush in to deal a killing blow.

Over the next several minutes, the two Executors fell silent. Demila sensed his new conviction. She frowned as he started ignoring her swords, conjured armor around his vitals, and cut down her clones one after the other. Nothing was able to stop him. Fellrun's assault grew so intense she stopped being able to summon two clones at once and occasionally dipped down to one for seconds at a time.

Demila had one saving grace. A special soul-link she possessed allowed her to swap places with any of her clones at a moment's notice, so long as they were within a certain range. Several times, Fellrun locked on to the correct Demila and nearly killed her, but she swapped at the last nanosecond and escaped by the skin of her teeth. She started to become worried as she sensed that her psionic energy was dipping.

So that's his plan. Demila thought. *He wants to exhaust me!*

Unfortunately, knowing about Fellrun's plan and being able to do something about it were two entirely different things.

He was just too fast! His control of the quadruple-nunchaku was picture-perfect! Once he drew within melee range, it was always over. Demila had no effective counter to him. He blocked her ranged attacks. Her close range attacks were too slow and clumsy. She now possessed a wide variety of abilities taken from stronger and weaker Psion souls, but she hadn't had time to practice with them. This battle was giving her precious experience in honing her abilities, but it wasn't nearly enough to train her in so many disciplines at once.

Suddenly, as Fellrun launched at her again, Demila had an idea.

Instead of attacking his physical body, she realized he had a weakness she hadn't considered yet.

Demila narrowed all of her eyes. She waited until Fellrun was about to attack her clone, then her real body sent a powerful micro-burst of telepathic energy at the side of Fellrun's head.

Fellrun sensed the impending danger, but he'd grown so used to Demila's pathetic attacks that he disregarded it. He cut down yet another of her clones right as his thoughts turned to garbled mush.

[Aaaah!!]

Fellrun's mind fell into disarray. His soul vibrated in agony. Electrical pain surged through all of his limbs, causing him to seize up. The momentary loss of control caused him to lose his grip on his weapon. One of the blades slashed down and sliced off his right leg at the knee, but he was in so much pain he didn't even notice. Then the nunchaku careened away, flying into the distance.

Fellrun, to his credit, quickly regained his mental focus. He snapped back to attention and motioned with his hand, only to belatedly realize he had lost his grip on his nunchaku. Then the pain of his lost leg hit him. It was, surprisingly, much less agonizing than whatever the hell Demila had struck his Mind Realm with a moment earlier. Psion physical bodies were not that prone to collapsing, even if they lost multiple limbs. Their minds were their most potent weapon, after all.

[Hahaha...] Demila laughed evilly, her eyes turning cunning. [I knew it. You hastily shoved your True Soul back into your body to prevent me from accessing it. But how can you assimilate your soul in so short a time? You've secretly been putting some effort into concealing the backlash! I wouldn't have noticed if you hadn't been so cautious until recently!]

Fellrun glanced at Demila. His expression gave no hints, but his stomach tightened in worry. The truth was, any Psion who died and revived inside a new body, or who moved their soul into a body, would suffer from Rejection Sickness. It was never deadly, but it always lowered the combat prowess of their body and made them temporarily vulnerable to mental and soul-based attack vectors. In his case, a week or two of meditation would allow him to properly align his body and soul, but he didn't have that kind of time. Demila had to be stopped!

Only now did he realize there was a fatal flaw in his plan. Demila was one of the strongest telepaths in the Volgrim Empire. She was well known for being able to read the surface thoughts of fellow 7th-Level Psions and much deeper and more private thoughts of weaker entities. Such a fine-tuned specialty wasn't much use against most opponents

usually, but in this one specific scenario... it meant the difference between victory and loss.

[No!] Fellrun shouted. He started to summon a new version of his weapon, only for Demila to mercilessly blast him with another beam of soul-rending telepathic energy. Fellrun's mind went blank and his body locked up, leaving him totally vulnerable to attack. Demila plunged her conjured swords into his heart, stomach, and neck, breaking his body on the spot. Before Fellrun could react, she swooped in and smashed her palm into his head, crushed his defenseless skull, and grabbed hold of his soul before it could dissipate.

Demila won.

She defeated an Executor previously considered the strongest among his kind. If it hadn't been for his one weakness, she would have lost.

But in the end, a win was a win, a victor was a victor, and a loser was a loser.

Demila grinned devilishly. She didn't hesitate before latching on to Fellrun's screaming soul and quickly sucking out its juices. Her power spiked, her exhaustion disappeared, and her energy recovered to its peak. At the same time, she was shocked to find that her Psionic Level came close to the apex of what an Executor could reach. Fellrun was an ancient monster like her, and he had many eras to consolidate his Seed. He was the highest quality Executor she'd eaten to date.

She hadn't made it to the 9th Level, but she was close. Deliciously close!

Psions might not have mouths, but Demila still metaphorically licked her lips hungrily. She drained Fellrun of everything he had, leaving his soul hollow, faded, and ready to dissipate into nothingness.

Demila hesitated.

Right now, she could could kill this mighty Executor with no effort at all. She could squeeze her fingers and pinch his soul into cosmic dust, or she could let it go and it would travel to the Great Beyond.

But she would never do either of these things. The other Volgrim might think she was a traitor, but Demila knew in her heart she was not.

Her methods were brutal, but her cause was just. She meant what she said. She intended to become the second 9th Level Psion. Founder Dosena would be spared. She

would have no choice but to accept Demila's rise. Dosena would begrudgingly have to live with the fact that she would remain as Volgarius's defender, while Demila would seek out and kill the Plague inside the Milky Way's hidden dimension known as the 'False Cosmic Realm.' With Dosena as the shield and Demila as the sword, the Volgrim would finally beat back the Plague and revive its future.

The other Volgrim were too short-sighted. They could not envision the breadth of Demila's grand plan. Though they thought her selfish now, they would realize that as the 6th Founder, she would be capable of conjuring other versions of herself, all equally as strong as her, and then projecting that power across the entire Milky Way.

What would those foolish so-called 'Demon Deities' be able to do when five of Demila's clones attacked their worlds all at once? They would bend the knee, or they would die!

Visions of grandeur flashed through Demila's mind. She easily saw the great future awaiting her. If she could only make it to the 9th Level, all her sins would not be in vain.

She held Fellrun's diminished soul in her grasp, feeling guilty about what she had done to him. That feeling passed. She traveled into the soul facility, where trembling and fearful Technopaths pressed themselves against the walls, looking at her as if she were a monster from a horror movie. She directed a look of pity their way, then placed Fellrun's soul into a soul prism where it would be held until he could revive as an Initiator.

[I know that you fear and hate me now.] Demila said to those Technopaths. [But someday, you will understand. Everything I have done is for the good of our Empire.]

"N-nonsense!" One of the bolder Technopaths shouted. "Lies! You are a traitor! Do you understand what you've done?! You've ruined us! Ruined us!!"

Demila sighed. She could kill him with a flick of her finger, but she would never harm another Volgrim. Even now, she had not killed a single Psion. She had drained their souls, yes, but they would revive. They would start over, anew, as Initiators. Humbled though they might be, they could start from scratch, advancing faster than they originally did, rebuilding their Seeds with knowledge of their future potential. It might take a few thousand years, but that was nothing compared to the millions she had lived.

The Volgrim Empire would endure. Someday, she would be championed as its savior. Its greatest hero! She might even be revered as the mightiest and wisest Founder!

As these thoughts flickered through Demila's mind, she forgot about the pitiful condemnations of the Technopath who dared to voice his opinion. He was not worth responding to. He could never grasp the sacrifice she had made, nor the full extent of her plans. It was not worth wasting a single iota of mental energy on him.

Demila levitated into the sky, then flew out of Naandril I's atmosphere.

Naandril III was her next target. With how close she was to the 9th Level, she knew her goal was as good as achieved.

Soon, she would obtain the accolades she deserved.

Soon, everyone would understand the wisdom of her actions...

Part 646: Demila's Destruction

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. Inside the sub-dimension of Chrona.

The happenings of the Volgrim Empire did not escape Fiona's gaze. As humanity's watcher, she oversaw it from afar. She viewed the galaxy from a distance, unable to make contact with it easily. Day by day, her connection network was breaking down bit by bit.

She watched as Demila revealed the hunger lurking within her soul. Her stomach roiled when the ancient monster turned to the wicked ways of the demons and began devouring the soul energy of her fellow Psions.

Eventually, after many weeks of watching, Fiona couldn't take it anymore. She turned away from the video feeds and left the Spynet Sphere.

She stepped back out into the main city of Chrona and looked up at the sky, although calling it that was a bit of a misnomer. Anyone could easily make out that the pitch-black void above was not natural, but artificial. They wouldn't see the light of the outer universe; only the sheen of the dimensional wall, and the faintly swirling gray cosmic energy that locked Chrona in place, accelerating its time and keeping it anchored to a secret position somewhere in the Milky Way.

The sounds of hammering drew Fiona's attention. She spotted a few of of Kar and Blinker's children up on some scaffolding, one of them nailing a board down as he worked to build a new residence. While there weren't a lot of crocodiles in Chrona, there weren't only a few, either. They numbered in the hundreds, and rumor had it Blinker was pregnant again. She'd probably give birth in the next few months, and the need for more housing would grow.

The young crocodile, a black-scaled member of the 13th generation, Romeo, seemed to sense Fiona's presence. He paused his hammering and waved. "Hurgh! How are you doing, Fiona?"

"I'm good." She responded. "Have you seen your mother?"

Romeo pondered the question for a moment before nodding to the west. "In the park."

"Alright, thanks!" Fiona said.

They didn't usually exchange many words. The crocodiles barely cared about the outside galaxy, and had no desire to travel and live out there. News of the Psion collapse certainly didn't make the outside galaxy feel secure, and though their life in Chrona might be humble, it was also pleasant.

Hundreds of years had passed in Chrona. The central city had grown noticeably more developed, especially with Rebecca casually offering pointers on city design once in a while. Her neural net possessed several exabytes of data on classical and futuristic city designs, courtesy of ancient Earth and many modern Volgrim cities around the galaxy, so she was a huge help in streamlining the city's infrastructure.

Chrona was growing not only in population, but in size. Much like the Labyrinth, its borders expanded over time. The more life energy that accumulated, the greater its size would become, and the faster its rate of expansion.

To date, it had only increased in size by a modest ten percent... but more space to live in was still good news for everyone involved. There was plenty of room for all Chrona's inhabitants now, but nobody could predict the situation in another hundred or even a thousand years.

Fiona wandered westward until she reached a pretty little park Blinker and Rebecca had been growing over time near the center of Chrona's central city. It featured a miniature artificial river that swept through it in an S-curve, a large central fountain with a statue of Jason holding his bo staff and water coming out of his outstretched palm, and lots of flowers and trees. So many shrubs and flowers lined the perimeter that they became a visual treat for anyone who wanted to sit down and enjoy a colorful setting.

Fiona entered the park, and in less than a minute she found Blinker sitting on a bench under a tree, nursing baby Timothy. He was barely a year old, and without his mother around, the only options for properly feeding him were some sort of baby formula, or a wet nurse. As a mother of many, Blinker agreed to take on that role, since Fiona could not.

Fiona sat on the bench, her spiritual body containing enough mass thanks to Chrona's improvements that she nearly felt like a real flesh and blood person. She sighed heavily, and Blinker looked at her.

"Still only bad news?"

"Pretty much." Fiona muttered, laying her head back and sighing even deeper. "Demila's rampage is drawing to a close. She's devoured all three Psion soul-worlds. Once she finishes eating all the souls on Naandril III, she'll be... I don't even know. I have no idea what her plans are, but they won't be good for humanity."

Blinker fell silent for a time. She looked off into the distance wistfully.

"Chrona is so peaceful, sometimes I forget about the pain and suffering happening outside its boundaries." Blinker murmured. "If we want to make a difference, we need to work harder."

"While true, we have a major problem on our hands which will soon complicate things." Fiona responded. "The time dilation is only continuing to increase in speed. We're already progressing at 290x the speed of the outside universe. By the time Timothy is an adult, we'll probably be at 300x, or maybe even 325x. I've lost control of a few Spynet cameras already. If the rate of speed continues to increase, a future where we become fully cut off from the outside galaxy is likely to occur. We won't be able to communicate with anyone due to the speed differential, and we won't be able to see what's happening out there."

"Are our lives in danger?" Blinker asked worriedly.

"As long as we stay in here? Probably not. We will continually adjust to the increasing speed. Our bodies will compensate. I am a spiritual life-form. You and Kar have extremely powerful physical and spiritual bodies. Your kids are no different. But Timothy... well, he's an ordinary human. I fear he might suffer physical issues as the time dilation increases."

"He's not ordinary, though." Blinker pointed out. "Daisy was a Hero, just like her daddy. I bet Timothy will be, too."

That only elicited another deep sigh from Fiona. She lifted her head again and turned to look at Timothy, then she gently ran her fingers through his soft blonde baby hair.

"A Hero. Yes. He probably will be. And that worries me, too. I don't want him growing up with the burden of feeling like he has to match up to his father and save humanity."

"But humanity does need saving." Blinker pointed out. "Jason's gone, Fiona. Gressil... killed him."

"We don't know that." Fiona said quietly.

Blinker looked at Fiona, then looked away.

The last time they saw Jason, he had been crying in a hallway, despondent from losing his wife. Then his signal vanished and a vacuum of spiritual energy engulfed the area.

Gressil had appeared.

The next time they saw Jason, it was when Gressil tossed his and Phoebe's lifeless bodies out in front of countless spectators in the Core.

Gressil didn't kill Phoebe. At least, Fiona was pretty sure he didn't. Though, considering Phoebe had died the moment she arrived inside Chrona, it might be possible he did. And whether he did or didn't, all evidence pointed to the fact that he did finally kill Jason in his moment of weakness.

But Fiona had a feeling. A gut instinct. She refused to believe Jason was dead. Maybe Gressil was deceiving them. He was a master of illusions, after all. Jason's body could have been fabricated!

...Except, she had reacquired him and Phoebe both. She teleported them to Chrona and put their bodies in stasis. If the bodies she recovered were fakes, they were good ones. Every scan Rebecca ran came up green for a perfect match on both.

They were Jason and Phoebe's bodies, without a doubt.

The thought Jason might actually be dead constantly made Fiona feel lightheaded. Sometimes, she wanted to burst into tears.

Jason was married to Phoebe, not Fiona. But Fiona knew she was lying to herself when she said she felt nothing for him. Of course she loved Jason. She loved him so much it made her heart bleed. It wasn't fair. If she hadn't been the clone, and Phoebe had, then Fiona would have died along with her husband.

But she was still alive, while Jason and Phoebe had joined each other in the Great Beyond.

Now, she was all alone... left to care for the child of her 'rival'. But Fiona couldn't bring herself to complain. She simply pretended to herself that Timothy was hers. He wasn't, and she wouldn't lie to him when he grew old enough to understand... but in her heart, it made life just a little bit more bearable if she could fool herself once in a while.

"We don't know he's dead." Fiona repeated, trying to convince herself more than the Fairy Queen beside her.

Blinker didn't retort. She didn't want to hurt Fiona's feelings, but the truth was obvious. It wouldn't do anyone any good to insist on repeating what both women already knew.

"Do we have a way to fix the time dilation?" Blinker eventually asked.

"We relied entirely on Jason manually slowing Chrona down when it started to accelerate." Fiona replied. "There is no fallback option. And if you try to leave Chrona, you'll go through the same thing you did before. You may even die if you try."

Blinker grimaced. She might live in Chrona now, but she spent the vast majority of her life in the outside universe. She didn't want to be locked into a tiny little world like Chrona, let alone all of her kids.

"My fairy magic is capable of a lot of things." Blinker eventually said. "I'm going to try getting in contact with Fairy Queen Calanthra. Maybe she'll be able to offer me some pointers remotely. I might be able to solve the time dilation myself."

"I sure hope so." Fiona said. "Oh, looks like Timothy is done nursing. Want me to take over?"

Blinker nodded gratefully. She passed the baby over to his surrogate mother, and Fiona started playing with him in that cute way she always did.

The two women continued to talk, but after discussing such dark happenings, they instead drifted off into more mundane and peaceful topics...

On the world of Volgarius, Founder Unarin stood at the edge of the landing pad inside the Founder's Thumb. He held Founder Dosena in his arms, while his Head Administrator, Muuxunuu, stood beside him, her arms folded in front of her waist. They both gazed off into the distance, looking at smoke from countless collapsed stratoscrapers. Eventually, the Volgrim had managed to stop the domino effect of collapsing structures, but the damage dealt was truly incalculable. Over two trillion Low Psions, Technopaths, and Changelings had perished. A hundred thousand stratoscrapers had fallen, and it remained to be seen how many centuries their people would need to rebuild that which they had lost.

Assuming they even *could*. They likely did not have much time left. With the Psion army dead, they would not be able to prop up any meaningful resistance against the

Plague, which had amassed an unstoppable, nigh-unkillable army of its own Psions.

The Volgrim could no longer protect themselves. How could they protect the rest of the Milky Way? The demons would fall. The humans would fall. Everything would be subsumed by the voracious appetite of the Plague.

Unstoppable. Uncompromising.

The faceless monstrosities held neither malice nor mercy. They devoured all life without remorse, like a tsunami engulfing a city.

They were like a force of nature... though nothing about them was natural in the slightest.

Despite all the horrible happenings, Unarin's expression did not change. He simply looked out at the distant smoke as if none of it had anything to do with him.

"Ten million cycles." Unarin remarked lightly. "And now, the end has come for our people. There have been shorter-lived Empires. There have been longer-lived ones, as well. I suppose all good things must eventually come to an end. What do you think, Muuxunuu?"

He looked at the blank face of his wife. She had long ago ceased to be a living, breathing Sentient with thoughts and emotions.

Now, she was only a robotic, lifeless husk. A pale remnant of her former self.

"Yes. All good things must end." Muuxunuu repeated.

Unarin faintly smiled. To him, there was one good thing that had disappeared from his life many millions of years before. Every time he looked at her, he was reminded of his greatest loss.

He had ceased to be an individual on that day. He had truly taken up the mantle of the Volgrim's leader. He had sacrificed everything to become the thing his people needed most.

And now?

His sacrifice meant nothing. It was all coming to an end.

Dosena stirred in Unarin's arms. She gurgled painfully, her telepathic voice shaky.

[Demila... is... coming.]

Despite her weakness, Dosena had remained fully aware of all the happenings around her. She suffered pangs of unending agony as a result of the Akashic Backlashes, but her mind remained sharp.

Unarin pursed his lips. He looked up into the sky, not entirely sure which direction Demila would arrive from.

[Put me... down.] Dosena said, her tone weak. [But help... me... stand. Help me lean.]

She forced a bit of vigor into her voice, but it was clear Dosena was not in any shape to fight. If Demila came with ill intentions, the Second Founder would be helpless. It was only because of her unbending pride that she refused to allow this stupid junior to see her helpless in Unarin's arms.

Unarin hesitated. Then, he nodded, and lowered her feet to the ground.

"Alright."

Dosena shuddered. Her knees clicked together as she tried to stand. Eventually, her face contorted in pain.

[Damn. I still... can't stand. This won't... do. How humiliating.]

After thinking for a moment, and knowing it wouldn't be long before Demila drew near, Dosena came to a decision. She shakily lifted an arm and motioned with her hand. A drop of golden liquid materialized in the air before her, making Unarin's heart skip a beat. He looked at her in shock, but she ignored him. Dosena levitated the liquid toward her forehead and pressed it against her glabella. It disappeared instantly, melting into her soul.

Just like that, her body regained a bit of strength. She hesitated for a moment, then pulled away from Unarin, beathing heavily. She reactivated her psionic powers and levitated off the ground, crossed her arms behind her back, and assumed her typical haughty, domineering posture.

"Dosena." Unarin said, his frown deepening even more. "You told me you wouldn't-"

[I will not be humiliated.] Dosena immediately replied. [This is my decision. Do not interfere.]

Her psionic power was still weak, but at least it had stabilized... *temporarily*.

Less than three minutes later, Dosena turned her head southward. Unarin followed her gaze. With his sharp eyes, he picked out many different specks in the horizon, but one of them accelerated at blinding speeds and rushed toward the Founder's Thumb far faster than any ship ever could.

That speck, as expected, turned out to be Demila. She roared toward the Founder's Thumb and came to an instant halt just twenty meters away from the landing platform. Her aura overflowed with power, and she crossed her arms, looking down on the insects before her with an expression of delight.

She had succeeded. She was no longer an Executor… but a true 9th Level Psion.

She was like Dosena, and the six other ancient Psions who came before her. Demila had finally joined the ranks of the most legendary monsters who once ruled the cosmos.

But neither Unarin nor Dosena looked at her with any level of appreciation. It was as if they had spotted a tumbleweed rolling past. Demila's legendary strength did not affect them in the slightest.

[Why the dour looks?] Demila asked haughtily. [I know my actions have distressed you, Founders. But rejoice! This is a great day for our Empire! It will be remembered for eons to come, as the moment we finally took back the initiative against our lessers.]

When neither of the Founders deigned to respond, Demila frowned, but continued speaking.

[I know you see only despair in our future, but you don't understand what has happened! Though Volgarius has suffered under the attack of that demon, Mephisto, it survived. It endured! And now, after harnessing the power of the demons, I have ascended to a level high enough to make a tremendous impact in the war against the Plague!]

Dosena narrowed her eyes, but before she could speak, Unarin did.

"The power of the demons, you say?" Unarin asked, putting on an expression of interest. "And what power would this be? It sounds impressive."

Demila smiled with her eyes. She liked hearing Unarin's words of praise. [The power of *Soul Manipulation*, First Founder Unarin. By devouring the energy of many souls, I was able to combine them with my own to Uplift myself. This power is a game changer! It could even alter the way we Psions ascend for millennia to come!]

Unarin appeared intrigued. "That does sound fascinating. Could you elaborate more on the specifics?"

Demila smiled with her eyes. It was as she expected. Unarin could not remain unmoved in the face of such an amazing new paradigm. The old way of building up power slowly over many centuries would not give the Psions a leg-up against their adversaries, but the shortcut of using Soul Manipulation would!

As such, Demila immediately launched into an explanation.

"You see, First Founder, you may have thought I devoured and killed off the other Psions, but that is not the case. I drained their soul energy, but all of them are still alive. They can revive in new bodies and start over from scratch, growing once again to new heights."

Unarin glanced at Dosena. He shrugged nonchalantly.

"So the Psions are still alive. I had heard that was the case, but it's good to receive confirmation from you." He said, returning his gaze to Demila. "It seems you did not go overboard."

Demila beamed with happiness. She had assumed she would arrive to an enraged Unarin, but he was actually taking this news rather well! He might even be receptive to her bold new idea.

[That's right, First Founder.] Demila continued. [And furthermore, I realized this new paradigm could result in a rapid explosion of Ascensions among the Psions. Think of it. A new Order, one where Psions progress not only by training their bodies and souls, but by competing among each other. If we harness the power of demons for ourselves, we could have them compete to swallow each other's powers, making the most worthy among them stronger, much faster than before.]

Unarin nodded along. "Hmm. Let me see if I understand correctly. You were told of an innovative new way of allowing Psions to ascend by a demon... Gressil, right?"

Demila smiled with her eyes. [Yes, First Founder.]

He nodded again, then rubbed his chin as he fell into thought. "Ahh, and this method involves devouring soul energy of other Psions to empower yourself. But, the problem comes in that you could not devour *all* the soul energy, right? You couldn't directly ingest the souls. Likely a limitation of demonic power to Psionic power."

Demila's smile faltered. [Y-yes. But... how did you know about that last part? I didn't mention...]

Unarin continued speaking. "Of course, in order to uplift yourself to Dosena's level, you had to devour a *lot* of souls. The energy conversion ratio must have been *atrocious*. How many trillions of Psions just to make one **Supremator**?"

Demila's expression turned to stone. Something about the way Unarin was speaking... how did he know so many specific details she hadn't even told him?

For the first time since Demila's arrival, Dosena finally lifted her head. She glowered at her junior, directing an expression of pure venom at Demila.

[Demila. You... you foolish... stupid... BRAINDEAD... traitor to our people.]

Demila's heart jumped. Why had the atmosphere changed so abruptly? What was she missing? Why were the Founders suddenly acting so differently from before?!

[W-what?] Demila asked. [This is... this is good news for our Empire! Why are you acting so-]

[OUR Empire?!] Dosena roared, her eyes turning bloodshot with rage. [You have the GALL to lecture the Founders about our future after you, in your insipid ignorance, destroyed that future?! This is not YOUR Empire! You did not build it! You did not uplift it from its ancient war-ridden ways into a peaceful utopia! YOU are nothing more than an attention-seeking bastard who has destroyed countless millennia of accumulation all to satisfy her own GREED!]

Deosena snapped her hand up and pointed a shaking finger at Demila, who by now had realized something had gone very, very wrong. She was clearly overlooking something dreadfully important... she just didn't know what.

[Gressil LIED to you!] Dosena shrieked. [And you fell for it, because you are an insecure, pathetic excuse for a Psion! He did not grant you any special 'powers' belonging to the demons. Those were latent powers ALL Psions already possessed. They were a scourge upon our species that Unarin and I explicitly took great steps to PURGE from our ranks! And you brought them back! YOU BROUGHT THEM BACK!]

Demila began to shake. She looked at the Second Founder with a mixture of confusion, disbelief, and horror.

[What? No! You're misunderstanding, Second Founder! It isn't what you think! These powers allowed the demons to devour souls and become stronger. They-]

[IMBECILE!!] Dosena screamed, wanting to rip her own face off in rage. [ALL Psions possess the ability to drain one another's soul energy. This cursed power led to countless civil wars among our people. It caused us to fight one another, eat each other, and turn on our own species with more fervor than we ever did our enemies. It ultimately led to the creation of the Sentinels, and nearly caused the extinction of all sentient life in the Milky Way!!]

Dosena grabbed at her head. Waves of agony emanated from her soul. She not only suffered from the lingering pain of the Akashic Backlash, but also the torture of remembering those dark, ancient times.

[No... no... it's not true.] Demila said, unable to believe what her senior was saying. She turned a hopeful gaze toward Unarin, but his expression said it all.

"Stupid Demila. Foolish descendant." Unarin said, his expression as cloudy as a stormy day. "Allowing you to go on as you always did, insecure in your failings, was the greatest mistake I ever made. You swallowed the power of countless promising seeds. You cut off their futures. Didn't you ever think of the long term mental fallout each Psion would feel once they realized they had been forced back to the starting point of their Journey? At least a third, maybe even two-thirds, are likely to commit suicide due to despair once we revive them! The loss of power is not merely a drop in strength, but a complete erasure of their life's work!"

Unarin pressed a palm against his face and rubbed it furiously, closing his eyes and laughing to himself at the absurdity of the situation.

"Hahaha! To think my glorious Empire would be undone by the greed and sniveling machinations of a coward like you, Demila! At least in the ancient times, Psions would fight one another to steal their opponent's Psionic Energy. But no! Not you! Not the Great Demila! You attacked your comrades while they were defenseless, sucking them dry while they couldn't even fight back! And you have the audacity to lecture us, acting as if you have even a shred of pride or honor left?!"

Unarin pulled his hand away from his face. He looked at Demila, who appeared completely crestfallen. Her entire aura had dissipated. She stood on the platform, unable

to control her Psionic powers properly. Her emotions were in such turmoil that she couldn't even properly form words.

[I... I didn't... mean... didn't know... couldn't...]

Demila pressed her palms against the sides of her head. Inside her soul, Desire was laughing unceasingly.

HAHAHA. YOU FELL FOR IT. YOU STUPID FEMALE. YOU BETRAYED YOUR ENTIRE SPECIES. YOU DID WHAT WE TOLD YOU, EXACTLY AS WE TOLD YOU. HAHAHA. HAHAHA!!! WE LED YOU BY THE NOSE, AND YOU WERE TOO STUPID TO EVEN ASK THE MOST BASIC OF QUESTIONS!! UNARIN IS RIGHT. YOU ARE A FAILURE, A PATHETIC, USELESS INSECT!

[No.. no... no...] Demila whimpered, all the joy of her ascension having completely vanished. It felt as if a void had swallowed her soul.

She felt empty. Completely empty, like a bowl that had all of its contents carelessly dumped out.

"Demila." Unarin said, folding his hands behind his back. "Do us all a favor. Spare the galaxy any further stupidity... and **kill yourself**."

Demila whimpered. She couldn't bring herself to look at the Founders. She couldn't look them in the eyes. She couldn't even bear to think about the crimes she had committed.

She had sinned. She had betrayed everything that made her... her!

At once, Demila stopped shaking. She stared at the ground for a moment.

Then... her body imploded.

Her Psionic Seed collapsed in on itself, instantly obliterating her physical existence and leaving nothing behind but her Seed itself.

Creator Demila, traitor of the Volgrim Empire... had perished.

Dosena reached out and grabbed Demila's Psionic Seed. She looked at it for only a moment, then crushed it in her hands, dissipating it to dust.

A long silence followed.

Volgarius's winds blew against Dosena, Unarin, and Muuxunuu's bodies with a gentle warmth.

Unarin looked out at the horizon and shook his head.

"We could have restored a few Executors with her Seed's remnant."

Dosena snarled at him. [We will *never* return to the old ways. Not once. *Not ever*. No compromises.]

Unarin shrugged. "Whatever you say. It doesn't matter, anyway. We're already doomed."

He cleared his throat, then turned to his Administrator.

"Muuxunuu. Call the other Founders. I want a meeting by day's end."

"Yes, Founder Unarin." Muuxunuu replied.

Part 647: Keen Instincts

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR.

The destruction of the Volgrim Empire had begun with a speed far swifter than anyone could have imaged. Demila's rampage caused untold destruction not only to the Psions, but also to Volgarius itself. Admittedly, she herself had not damaged Volgarius, but as a result of her actions, Volgarius was left nearly defenseless, allowing Mephisto to rampage unhindered. He directly caused the death of a trillion Volgrim, and would have killed even more had Executor Nufaris not selflessly given his life to stop the demon-dragon hybrid.

However, all of this was unknown to the galaxy at large. Outside of a handful of individuals inside Chrona, Fairy Queen Calanthra, and some Cosmic-level observers, most Sentients had no idea such a horrible catastrophe had just befallen their former Overlords.

Despite several Demon Deities immediately comprehending what had just happened thanks to sensing the life energies of many different Volgrim Cosmics being snuffed out, they did not rejoice, and neither did they plan any celebratory attacks on their ambiguous enemy-allies.

That was because the collapse of the Volgrim Empire, even if they were a threat to the Demons, was absolutely not worth celebrating.

Indeed, the very few select demons in the know felt chills go down their spines. Demon Deity Auger met the gaze of his subordinate, Yardrat, and the two of them quickly lowered their eyes.

Demonkind was not ready. They hadn't had any time to prepare.

What did the deaths of all the High Psions mean? It meant there was no longer a Volgrim bulwark pushing against the Plague. The Kolvaxians would soon realize they were free to rampage unhindered... assuming they hadn't already.

The demons had no idea the culprit for the Volgrim's fall was one of their own. If the Deities knew, they might go berserk and hunt Gressil down, even if only to uselessly vent their anger.

That imbecile! Because of him, there was nothing stopping the damned Plague from devouring one world after another! Even if the world was guarded by a Middle Cosmic Deity, there was no guarantee they would be able to hold back one, two, or even three Kolvaxxed Executors, let alone an unlimited army of lower-ranking, but still deadly Kolvax-Psions!

Thus, Demon Deity Auger hurriedly convened the other leading Deities. They met at the world of Numaria, where Auger reigned. Only Auger attended in person, while the rest traveled there in Astral Bodies.

They were all of the same mind.

"We cannot fight the humans anymore." Melody proclaimed. "Set aside your petty hatred. We need to let them breathe. Let them grow! We have no way to fight the Plague when it attacks, so we have to start putting as many eggs in as many baskets as we can!"

Normally, the other Deities would nod along to her words, but secretly scoff in their hearts. They all knew she was pro-human to an annoying degree. But this time was different. They truly had no backup! They didn't even know where to start with engineering a counter to the Plague. Diablo was their first, final, and only hope... and he was dead.

"Agreed." Kristoff, one of the most mild-mannered Deities, replied. "Say what you want about the humans, but they are annoyingly good at finding the weaknesses of whoever is their greatest enemy, then punching holes through them."

The Demon Deity of Devouring glanced around at the other Deities after he finished his affirmation. He stared at Auger for an unusually long time, prompting the de facto leader of demonkind to lift his chin and sigh.

"This is a truly terrible day for the galaxy." Auger said, stroking his long white goatee as he spoke. "The tides of change are fickle and prone to disaster. Not only must we set aside our petty rivalries with the humans, we must also protect and shield them. We must send demons to help them quickly build any facilities they might need. We should also proactively check with each of the monster species to see if any of them can assist in creating a counter to the Plague."

"The fairies are a good place to start." Vespera, the Deity of Quasars, intoned. She crossed her arms melodramatically, her long black elbow gloves pressing against one another as she swept her gaze around the ring of Deities. "I will not lie, though. Relying

on the humans leaves a sour taste in my mouth. Would that we had a champion of our own, a cerebral powerhouse, we would not be in such an unfortunate situation."

Yardrat's eyes dimmed. "We never understood how important Ose was to our species until she was gone. I'd sacrifice a trillion lesser demons, or even offer up my own life for the good of demonkind, if it meant we could revive her. Serena, is there a chance your magic might be able to find a trace of her soul?"

The Soulmancer, Serena, lightly shook her head. "Even if I could, that damned Demila and her antics led to Tarus II being destroyed, and along with it the last remnants of Valac's Lantern. We have no way of bringing back the dead."

A flicker of intent snapped across Auger's eyes. "What of Bael? He inhabits Ose's body, yes? I know he is a dimwit and a fool, but is there truly no way we could somehow tap into Ose's brain to reignite her psyche?"

Serena sighed. "If only things were that simple. I am a master of souls, not of brains."

The Deities fell silent again.

"What of Ose's close friend?" Melody asked. "Might she know something?"

"Close friend? Ose had no friends." Yardrat scoffed. "She was always so arrogant and full of herself, nobody even bothered to try."

"No." Vespera said, looking at Melody with interest. "You're wrong, Yardrat. There is one who, unreasonably, enjoyed basking in Ose's presence. Abby, the Baron of Happy Thoughts. She is unimpressive as far as demons go, but she is a Baron nonetheless. She and Ose spent a lot of time together, especially during the Energy Wars."

The other Deities nodded along to Vespera's words, wondering why they had not connected the dots before this point.

"Beelzebub might know something too, in that case." Yardrat pointed out. "He and Ose were oddly close, even if only for a short time. Maybe she informed him of a backup plan in case she were to die?"

"I don't think Beelzebub is going to tell *us* anything." Melody replied blandly. "Well, he *might* tell me, but even I think that's a stretch. As for the rest of you, you're on his shit-list."

The other demons glowered at Melody, but they had no retort. It was abundantly clear that whatever damned voodoo the Wordsmith had worked on him, Beelzebub had

fundamentally switched sides and become humanity's greatest champion!

And, most dreadfully, he possessed the power of a Middle Cosmic! Not only that, but he had chased Executor Nufaris across multiple star-systems, so it was clear he wasn't like the other Deities, tethered to a star.

Just how in the world did he do it, every Deity including Melody wondered. *He wasn't uplifted by Diablo. Did he break through the boundary all on his own? If so, that meant he might be in possession of an unbelievably valuable secret!*

The other Deities sobered up. They realized all together that Beelzebub could either become demonkind's greatest enemy, or its benefactor! If they made amends and somehow wrangled the secret of ascension out of him, then even more demons could arise, and suddenly the danger of the Plague wouldn't be so alarming. It might not be scary at all! An armada of Middle Cosmics would be able to locate the Plague's source and destroy it on the spot, ending its threat forever!

Auger gritted his teeth. This next part would be... unpleasant.

"We... must do more than make amends with the humans." He said slowly. "We must also sincerely apologize to Beelzebub. He is a valued Deity, like the rest of us. Whatever demands he makes, we should do our best to fulfill them. Let us put aside the ills of the past and work toward a better future with humanity."

The other Deities nodded and raised their fists in agreement. Melody rolled her eyes and sighed. It was painfully obvious what Auger wanted, but to be honest, Melody was just as curious as he was.

How in the *god damn hell* did that Beelzebub do it?!

Auger looked around the gathered Deities.

"So. Are we all in agreement?" He asked.

The others nodded in unison.

"Then by our gathered wills, let it be done." Auger proclaimed.

On the world of Grimvolas, the Fifth Founder, Cinculu, stood at the ready. Before him was the planet's lone Warpgate, the very first one ever made, even preceding Volgarius's

many gates. Grimvolas's portal did not activate often, and the majority of times when it did open, the reason was to allow Cinculu to make a pilgrimage to Volgarius.

Cinculu was a formidable creature. His body was overflowing with strength and vitality. Few knew just how dangerous he truly was, and none of those in the know lived on Volgarius.

He wore a golden ceremonial set of armor. It didn't offer him much protection, but it looked resplendent. It glittered under the midday sunlight of Grimvolas's golden star.

An even bigger Dolgrimite lumbered up beside Cinculu.

"Child. I have ordered two of your brothers to join you on this trip."

Cinculu turned to look at his mother, the Dolgrimite Matriarch, the most powerful of their people.

"That is out of the ordinary. I do not usually travel to Volgarius with an escort."

The Matriarch spread her mouth in a long, toothy smile.

"Unusual times call for unusual methods. You know well what today means. It is finally the end of the technology lovers' era. They will learn the error of their ways. You will open their eyes to the Truths of the universe."

Cinculu lifted his chin, ever so slightly. "You expect me to put on a show of force?"

The Matriarch rested her powerful hand on his shoulder. Her grin grew even wider.

"These fools put their faith in useless 'Cosmics'. What good is power if it means one must be shackled by Akasha's will? Even if Dosena were still a threat, I know you would not disappoint me. And without her? Well. You know what to do."

She stepped to the side, and a pair of male Dolgrimites approached from behind. They stopped a short distance away and bowed their heads respectively.

"I have lost count of the moons since I last traveled to the world of the metal-lovers." The first Dolgrimite, a yellow-scaled fellow named Virile, said. Virile wore a religious robe of red and gold. He walked with a staff and hunched over as if he were of advanced age. His ceremonial attire was not that of a combat master like Cinculu, but that of a religious leader known for his wisdom and grand thoughts.

Virile sighed. "The times are changing. As my old friend Vedric used to say... the future cannot be predicted, only foreseen up to a specific point. Even he knew not what lay

beyond the Great Shattering."

The other Dolgrimite was a much nastier looking fellow. He wore a red and silver garb, one that clung loosely to his body and allowed him to move freely as if he were in the nude. His robes were just as ceremonial as the other too, but they had in their design a hint of his blood-hungry nature.

"It is a shame Demila betrayed the Psions." The second Dolgrimite, Ravagil, said. He looked at the Warpgate as if he wanted to take a bite out of it. Not due to hunger, but pure loathing of its technology-based ways. "I would have liked to fight them."

"As would I." Cinculu said, looking appreciatively at his brother Ravagil. "In time, I suppose more will rise. We can always fight them then."

Ravagil squeezed his claws together. He closed his eyes and winced as a pang of deep hunger ran through his body. The feeling disappeared, and he returned to normal.

"What is the holdup?" Ravagil impatiently asked. "Let us depart already."

"Calm down." The Matriarch said, casting a chilling glance at her child. Surprisingly, Ravagil didn't even bat an eye. The Matriach could probably fold him in half if she hit with all her strength, yet he knew nothing of the word 'fear'. He was truly fearless to a psychotic level.

"The calculations are nearly complete. Only another three time units, and we will depart." Cinculu said diplomatically.

The three of them fell silent. They waited patiently, and finally, the Warpgate whirred to life. A blue portal materialized in its center, eventually revealing the fourth warpgate nexus of Volgarius on the other side.

Cinculu strode through. His brothers followed behind him. They emerged inside a surprisingly barren facility, where only a handful of Technopath and Changeling delegates awaited their arrival. Among them was a single Psion, only of the 2nd Level. In the past, Cinculu had never been met by a Psion below the 6th Level. This spoke of the heavy loss the Empire had just suffered; it barely had any Psions left, and those who Demila had missed were either the scattered few with their True Souls inside their bodies, and the recently Initiated, who were still at the beginning of their journey.

Psions were not considered military-ready until they reached the 5th Level. Before that, they were only allowed to go on exploration missions of special-class danger-worlds,

diplomatic investigations of Mud Dwellers, and excursions designed to teach fledgling Initiators the fundamentals of their powers in highly controlled environments.

Cinculu frowned. Seeing his displeasure, the young Psion shuddered. He couldn't believe he'd been entrusted with such a mission! It would have been the highest honor of his life if he didn't know that he was one of the last available options to receive the Fifth Founder. He was woefully underprepared for such a heavy duty.

[F-Fifth Founder, it is my pleasurable- my, my pleasure to meet you in the person- in person.] The Psion stammered. [I am Learner Mailor-]

"I don't care who you are." Cinculu said, crossing his arms and sneering at the stammering fool of a Psion. "If I wish to know, I'll ask. Alright, then. Let's get this farce over with. Hurry up and take me and my brothers to the Founder's Fingers!"

One of the Technopaths blinked. "Your brothers? I was not informed you would be bringing guests. This meeting is for the Founders only, Fifth Founder. I mean no disrespect, but-"

"Shut up." Cinculu hissed. "My brothers are my family. I have brought them along as extra security, since Volgarius can no longer be considered safe. Are you able to accommodate them, or are we about to have a *problem*?"

The Technopath hesitated, then slowly shook his head.

"No, Fifth Founder. There is no problem. We will make the necessary arrangements. Please give us a short time to procure a larger travel-bus with the necessary security features."

Cinculu snorted. He strode out of the Warpgate chamber, along with Virile and Ravagil, and the other Volgrim had no choice but to fall into line behind them. The Technopath rapidly communicated with the landing pad, and by the time they made it to the hangar bay on the upper floors, he was ready to give a report.

"Due to the unexpected nature of this request, we will require thirty time units to reroute a larger shuttle this way." The Technopath said apologetically, as they stepped inside the busy, bustling inner hangar area. All around them, ships landed and took off, and the people who had been forced to wait outside the Warpgate Chamber until the Fifth Founder had left hurried inside, ready to travel to their next destination.

Cinculu glared at the Technopath, but he said nothing. In truth he didn't *have* to ride the shuttle to the Founder's Fingers, but his method of traveling on his own would cause... a certain level of unwanted destruction.

The group remained silent as the minutes began to pass. Cinculu's attention wavered. He glanced over to the edge of the room, where a waiting area with food formula and liquid mix allowed travelers to rejuvenate their bodies before they traveled.

There, he saw something most peculiar. A group of Technopaths were sitting around a table, holding onto thin rectangular pieces of metal, each one etched with numbers, symbols, or faces. These faces consisted of Unarin, Dosena, and Treyza, each painted different colors.

Cinculu watched as the Technopaths kept looking at one another with deep suspicion. They picked up additional pieces of metal sometimes, called out bets other times, and were very careful about doing things he couldn't quite understand.

"What are those fools doing over there?" Cinculu asked, less out of a desire to know what was going on, and more to sate his momentary boredom.

The Technopath lowered his head apologetically. "I am sorry you had to see this, Fifth Founder. It is a new craze taking over Volgarius called Volgrim Hold'Em. It is a tactical exercise involving deception, gambling, and other unauthorized activity. We have tried to crack down on it, but the exercise is extremely compelling, and countless Technopaths have begun to engage in it. Rooting out the behavior has proven troublesome."

Cinculu massaged his chin. He wandered over to watch the tactical exercise, and the players stiffened in horror when they saw him approach.

"F-F-Fifth Founder?!" One of the Technopaths exclaimed, the fear of his makers coming over him. "Ah, this is not what it appears! We only-"

"No need for alarm." Cinculu said, raising his claw in a neutral gesture. "I am here to assess this tactical exercise. Explain it for me."

The Technopaths nervously looked at one another. Even though they had been engaging in the tactical exercise in a public area, they assumed because so many other Volgrim were doing the same thing all over Volgarius, nobody had any reason to pay them special attention. Now they felt as if death had come to greet them with a friendly handshake and a dagger behind its back.

One of the more mentally fortified and older Technopaths, a fellow named Loputo Zimri, was the first to speak.

"It would be my honor to explain the rules of engagement, Fifth Founder. You see, this exercise is all about using limited information to engage in a form of cerebral warfare..."

Zimri began to explain the rules to Cinculu. The Fifth Founder barely held any interest at first, but after a few minutes of listening, his tail began to swish back and forth behind him. He glanced at the tactical cards, then thought about how much time he had before the shuttle arrived.

"Mmm. I suppose a round or two of Volgrim Hold'Em would not hurt. Alright, I wish to try this training exercise for myself. Deal me in."

One of the Technopaths quickly stood up and made room, allowing Cinculu to sit. Zimri started dealing cards out, speaking as he did so. "It is important not to cheat by using enhanced senses, technology, or psionic abilities in this exercise. One must rely purely on their keen instincts to defeat their adversaries."

Cinculu sneered at Zimri. "You lot are ones to talk. Slaves to the machine. Believers in welded metal and circuitry. My instincts have been trained over eons. You have no chance of defeating me in a trivial training exercise of this level."

Zimri hesitated. "I... fear your reaction if we do triumph. Fifth Founder, please forgive my impudence. Will you... let us off easily if one of us succeeds in defeating you?"

Cinculu barked out a derisive laugh. "Baha! Listen to you! You actually believe you have a chance, metal-slave! But don't you worry. I am not a petty creature. Even if I do lose, I will not hold it over your head. It only means I need to train my instincts harder!"

The Technopaths sighed quietly in relief. Some of the tension at the table evaporated.

"I see." Zimri said slowly. "Then I must thank you in advance for your mercy."

* * *

Fifteen minutes later, Cinculu's claws trembled in rage.

"No! No! Seven losses in a row?! Impossible! You are using your devices to cheat after all!"

"We are not." Zimri retorted. "You have allowed your emotions to get the best of you, Fifth Founder. You have many 'tells' when certain tactical cards enter your hand. Your

pupils dilate in excitement when your hand is worth a satisfactory number of points."

"And you start breathing at a seven-point-five percent increased rate." Another Technopath chimed in.

"You are entirely too predictable." Zimri said, looking at Cinculu with a hint of pity. "Unfortunate. I expected the Fifth Founder to be a bit more... fearsome in this exercise."

"Listen to you! Hahaha! You sure have guts, speaking that way to a Founder!" Cinculu barked. "Again!"

One of the Technopaths gestured behind Cinculu. "Founder, your shuttle arrived seven time-units ago. Your comrades have already boarded and are waiting for you."

Cinculu didn't even look backward. "They can wait. Winning this tactical training exercise is much more important! I will not let the name of Dolgris be defamed by usurpers and metal-mouths!"

"...If you insist." Zimri said.

Three hours later, Cinculu shakily stood up from the table. He gruffly bowed, then stormed away.

He failed to win even one hand. He had gone all-in on fifteen occasions and lost everything, and even having all the chips be redistributed evenly time after time did nothing to help his odds.

As he stomped up the ramp into the shuttle and sat down, Ravagil glanced at him.

"Finally done toying with your inferiors?" Ravagil asked.

Cinculu's eye twitched. He crossed his arms and looked at his brother with a stormy expression.

"I do not wish to speak of it! Now be silent and let me collect my thoughts."

Virile snickered to himself. He couldn't remember a time he had ever seen the Fifth Founder so flustered.

Maybe there was something *special* about this Volgrim Hold'Em training exercise...

He would have to look into it later.

Author Notes: Hey guys, hope you enjoyed the part! I prompted ChatGPT to make a few images of these Dolgrimites and I'm very happy with how they came out! Check them out below.

Original design of the Dolgrimites, by MWTX

Cinculu, by ChatGPT

Virile, by ChatGPT

Ravagil, by ChatGPT

Yeah, the designs fucked up the feet by giving them 3 claws instead of 2, and they definitely aren't perfect, but I like that it gives you guys a little something to look at for future reference! More TCTH soon!

Part 648: Fallen Empire

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR.

The shuttle traveled for a full hour, moving much slower than usual due to high atmospheric traffic. As the three Dolgrimites made their pilgrimage to the Founder's Fingers, Cinculu occasionally ordered the pilot to make small detours. He did this so he could observe the destruction caused by Mephisto with his own eyes. Holo-recordings disgusted Cinculu. He knew he could only trust the Truths of reality if they had not been distorted by the false gods of technology.

Countless stratoscrapers lay in ruins. Fire burned across tens of thousands of acres, beneath billions of tons of exosteel and spatial glass. These stratoscrapers were made with construction knowledge built up over millions of Volgrim cycles. They were extremely durable, constructed to survive Category 11 planetquakes (not that Volgarius ever had those), and even an atomic detonation wouldn't cause them to collapse, only to destroy their softer internal areas and the Sentients contained within.

Yet, within only a few minutes of rampaging, Mephisto caused this much devastation. The power of even a pitiful bottom level Cosmic could not be underestimated. No mere Demon Emperor would be able to wreak so much havoc in so short a time.

Cinculu stared out the window silently. He and his brothers witnessed the destruction with dark expressions.

"Such loss is always sad." Virile said, his aged eyes looking down upon the ruined buildings with melancholic fervor. "You must pity the metal-dwellers. They place so much faith in the falseness of their technology, that they are blinded to its inadequacies. Their soft bodies, weak to the desires of comfort and convenience, make them susceptible to the corrupting whispers of steel."

"It is not their fault." Cinculu affirmed. "Though they are heretics who have committed sacrilege against their true god, they are victims of Unarin's manipulation. He has placed himself at the top of the hierarchy, believing himself to be the savior of our people. Yet because of his actions, the Plague has brought ruin to the galaxy."

Ravagil growled sinisterly within the depths of his throat. "These slaves to metal will soon remember who their god is... or they will die gnashing their teeth while begging

Dolgris for mercy."

The pilot of the shuttle, a low-ranking Technopath, wisely kept his mouth shut and eyes forward. He feared that whatever he was overhearing might lead to his death if he leaked even a single word! No matter how loyal he might be to the Founders, these Dolgrimites were mean, massive, and terrifying! They could rip him apart and eat the skin off his bones!

What he did not know was that the Dolgrimites simply did not care if he overheard. They knew that Unarin was aware of their distaste for the Council. Unarin was no fool, and he had long been aware of the Dolgrimites' hatred for those they deemed the 'metal-born'. But he never felt he had anything to worry about, so long as the Psions reigned over his Empire.

What good would Dolgrimites be when Psions could bombard and destroy planets from space? They were no threat at all. Better to let them grumble and whine in the sanctuaries of their halls rather than give them more attention than they deserved.

But that was then, and this was now.

With the Psions dead, Unarin was sure to be sweating as he realized those supposed religious nutjobs were now coming toward him with hostile intent!

Cinculu grinned as he thought of this. His earlier humiliation in the tactical exercise had already started to fade from his memory. Just because the metal-lovers managed to trick him with their heretic sorcery, that did not mean his instincts were inferior. The heretics could not be trusted!

The shuttle flew toward the Founder's Thumb and docked inside its hangar. The Dolgrimites strode down the landing ramp with Cinculu in the lead, his back upright and a haughty air about him.

At the bottom of the ramp, a familiar figure stood.

"Fifth Founder. Greetings."

"Ah, Lady Muuxunuu." Cinculu said, smiling politely at the pink-skinned Ascended before him. "No Unarin?"

"The other Founders have already assembled in the Founder's Soul." Muuxunuu explained emotionlessly. "They are waiting on you."

Cinculu smirked. "Good. Better than me having to wait on them."

Muuxunuu looked at the other two Dolgrimites behind him, but said nothing. Wordlessly, she turned around and gracefully began walking out of the hangar, leading them deeper into the Founder's Thumb.

The first thing Cinculu noticed was how different the atmosphere of Volgarius felt. Because Psions always radiated a faint level of power, their emotions and suspicions could cause non-Psions to feel uneasy; like they were being watched. This was often more true than not. Especially inside the Founder's Thumb, where Dosena's presence could always be felt.

But this time was different. That omnipresent feeling of being watched seemed to have completely disappeared. Realizing this emboldened Cinculu even more. Clearly, the rumors were true, and Dosena was in no condition to use her powers.

The Volgrim Empire was weak. It was ripe for the taking...

Muuxunuu directed the Dolgrimites to the entryway leading into the Founder's Soul. This was a special chamber used when the Founders convened, and it only had five seats inside.

Before Muuxunuu opened the door, Cinculu smiled at her from behind. "My brothers will be joining me today. I hope that isn't a problem."

"No. It is not." Muuxunuu replied. "Founder Unarin already anticipated this would be the case. He has provided additional seating."

Cinculu blinked. He didn't have a response.

He couldn't believe it. How would Unarin possibly know he planned to bring Virile and Ravagil with him into the Founder's Soul? Surely, he would have expected them to stand guard outside? Cinculu had never done such a thing since the Founders had first assembled!

He grimaced. Obviously, Unarin was playing with him. Toying with his mind. That damned bastard, he might be weak and reliant on his Psion underlings to do the dirty work, but his predictive capabilities were the real deal.

Muuxunuu pushed the door open, revealing the other Four Founders within.

At an ornate pentagonal stone table, instead of five chairs, there sat seven. Each of the table's five sides had only one seat, except for the side nearest the door, where there were three. The seats were jammed rather uncomfortably close together, making it so if the

Dolgrimites chose to sat down together, they would literally be rubbing elbows, and would probably appear more silly than intimidating.

Cinculu's eyes flickered slightly as he instantly noticed this fact. Unarin was toying with him again, all to throw him off-balance!

Then Cinculu looked around the table. At the opposite side, Founders Unarin and Dosena sat, while on their right and left, Founders Treyza the Changeling and Cuanali the Technopath sat. The four of them stared silently at Cinculu as he paused in the doorway for half a step.

Cinculu's gaze flickered to Dosena. She appeared healthy and vibrant, but he couldn't feel her psionic senses sweeping over him in that creepy and invasive way she always did. In fact, she was only using her eyes! Like a common peasant! Certainly a bizarre thing for her to do, and likely only happening because of her current weakness.

"Cinculu." Unarin said, after a few moments of silence. "So nice of you to finally join us. I started to wonder if you'd show."

The Fifth Founder smiled, but his expression lacked sincerity.

"Apologies. I ended up sightseeing for a bit, looking upon the destruction wrought by that demon dragon. Today was not a good day for you."

Unarin slowly blinked. "It is not a good day for the *Empire*, dear Cinculu. Now, if you and your brothers would take your seats, we can begin discussing the steps we need to take to prepare our final stand."

Muuxunuu stepped outside and closed the door, but Cinculu shook his head at Virile and Ravagil. "You will stand behind me."

"Yes, Fifth Founder." Virile said.

He and Ravagil pulled their chairs away and lined them behind the wall, then stood beside Cinculu as he took his usual seat. They both clasped their claws in front of their waists and stood there looking as intimidating as they could. The other Founders didn't seem to notice.

"Dosena." Cinculu said, turning his attention to her. "Are you feeling well?"

Dosena simply looked at Cinculu and blinked her eyes. She didn't say a word.

"The Second Founder has temporarily lost control over all her psionic abilities." Unarin explained. "She cannot even use telepathy to communicate with us."

"Oh. That is unfortunate." Cinculu said, a hint of false concern buried in his tone. "Such a shame, Dosena. You're always such a delight to converse with."

Once again, Dosena merely stared at him, slowly blinking her eyes as if she did not suffer from a telepathic block, but instead did not deign to respond. Just by looking at her, it was obvious she found his presence grating.

Founder Treyza, ever the diplomat, lifted its hand from its chest and motioned into the air before itself. "Cinculu, this one is pleased you made time to attend. This one would have felt dismay if you were not present for the proceedings."

Unlike the other Founders, Cinculu didn't mind Treyza's presence. The Changelings might engage in twisted science and experiments, but they were not augmented like the Technopaths, nor wielders of psionics, nor the haughty and proud entities who named themselves 'Ascended' in their arrogance. Changelings were the most benign and neutral of the five Volgrim sub-species. As such, they generally got along well with everyone.

Cinculu smiled at Treyza. "How could I let you down? Of course I had to attend. This is a historical day for the Volgrim, after all."

"'Historical' is not the word I would use." Unarin retorted, his voice gruff. "Tragic, perhaps. Disastrous would be even more apt."

After a brief pause, Unarin waved his hand toward the center of the table, and a holographic map of the Milky Way materialized, zooming in to the local sectors.

"Due to Creator Demila's betrayal, the Psion Army has lost 99% of its fighting power. Nearly every Psion, especially those above the 2nd Level, have been debilitated and had their power drained, leaving them at the rank of Initiator. I need not spell out how long it will take to rebuild our army. As you can imagine, we simply will not be able to. We need time, and time is what we lack."

He paused before adding, "Thus, we must execute the Dying Light Initiative."

The other Founders remained silent. An ominous air filled the room as Treyza and Cuanali looked back and forth between Unarin and Dosena, and Founder Cinculu.

"Have we truly given up all hope?" Cuanali asked. Her body, more machine than biology, was the antithesis of Cinculu's beliefs. Of all the Founders, Cinculu detested her

existence the most.

"This galaxy is already lost." Unarin declared. "The only options we have left are to reactivate the Sentinels, or to begin full-scale planetary evacuations."

Treyza's face remained expressionless. "Evacuations will preserve less than one percent of the Volgrim population. The rest will be left to fend for themselves."

"They will be left to die." Cinculu growled. "So that's it, then? That's why you called everyone here, Unarin? To declare that we've lost the war, give up, and run away with your tail tucked between your legs?"

"The Dolgrimites have the most to lose." Unarin said smoothly. "Unlike the rest of us, you have only ever populated the original homeworld. You have given up chance after chance to extend your reach. That means you are balancing on the edge of a knife. If the Plague attacks Grimvolas, your species will be wiped out. As such, I am prepared to evacuate at least half of your planet's populace, perhaps even more if we can spare the ships."

Ravagil smirked at Unarin. He turned his head slyly and growled at his brother. "Hehe. You hear that, Virile? The First Founder says we're helpless against the Plague. My claws are *trembling* with fear."

Unarin sighed. "I know that you have faith in your... god... but this faith is misplaced. There are no Psions capable of protecting you. Across the entirety of the Volgrim Empire, there are less than a thousand Psions possessing power above the 4th Level. Most of them were Psions who died in battle and revived, moving their True Souls to their new bodies until the rehabilitation period concluded. They are in no condition to fight. Once the Kolvax-Psions arrive, your world will fall in less than a day."

Unarin spread out his hands. "If I am wrong and the Dolgrimites have some secret means of fighting back, this is your last chance to use it. I do not wish to reactivate the Sentinels, so evacuation is the only means we have left to preserve our key leaders and geniuses and rebuild anew in another galaxy."

"Hahaha!" Cinculu laughed, slamming his meaty fist onto the table. "Another galaxy! Oh, Unarin, you are a riot! You know as well as I that there exists no such galaxy free for the taking. If we cannot preserve this one with all the volpower at our disposal, then how can we possibly wrest away control of another galaxy with a fraction of our forces?"

"Admittedly, it is a long shot." Unarin replied, lowering his eyes. "We will need to bide our time until Dosena recovers. We will also need to nurture the few remaining Psions who did not have their powers drained. Confessor Vulpanix, for example, remains among the high-rankers. She is a promising seed, perhaps even on par with Executor Nufaris in terms of future potential. She was fortunate enough to have recently perished in battle and had her True Soul placed inside a new vessel. It won't be long before she regains her full strength."

"One 7th Level Psion. Well, I guess we're saved then!" Cinculu laughed, ridiculing Unarin's words. "Truly, you have fallen to the most desperate of measures!"

Unarin did not take Cinculu's bait. The Fifth Founder's attempts to rile up Unarin's emotions failed. He remained as steadfast as ever.

"Are you done?" Unarin asked. "Once again, this is your last chance, Cinculu. If you truly do have a 'god' who can protect you, now is the time to speak up."

Cinculu's mocking smile disappeared. He and Unarin stared at one another for several long, uncomfortable seconds.

How much does he know? Cinculu secretly wondered. *This is the second time he's asked such a leading question. Has he known all along? Impossible. He would have taken us much more seriously if that were the case. He must be desperately hoping we're not full of dung-droppings.*

Cinculu smiled once again.

Fortunately for him, we're not. But unfortunately, salvation will not come without its own price...

Instead of directly answering Unarin's question, Cinculu looked up at the holographic map of the galaxy above the table. He glanced around it for a moment, noting the familiar star systems.

"What planets are currently being ravaged by the Plague?"

Unarin's eyes flickered for a moment, as if uncertain about something.

"...There are 1,042 star systems currently under attack." Unarin said, after a moment's deliberation.

"That many? Hehe, the situation is certainly dire, indeed." Cinculu snickered.

"This is no laughing matter." Cuanali stated, turning her cold, robotic eyes to glower at him. "Do you find the suffering of your Volgrimkin amusing?"

"They are not my kin. They are heretics bound to the false gods of metal." Cinculu responded nastily, glaring back at Cuanali. He returned his gaze to Unarin. "Show me all the worlds currently under attack."

Unarin nodded. He motioned with his hand, and more than a thousand red dots appeared in the air above them. After a few moments, Cinculu pointed at one of them.

"I know this one. XR-Zanovra. What is its status?"

Unarin immediately called up the planet's information. It turned out to be a watery world 85% covered in ocean, with floating sky-islands suspended in midair through various technological processes. Supposing the Plague did not deliberately destroy them, they would likely remain aloft for a few hundred years before falling into the oceans due to a lack of maintenance. If the Plague *did* destroy their internal areas, then they would obviously fall much sooner.

"A Class C planet suitable for farming aquatic biological matter necessary for nutrient supplements." Unarin stated. "It is currently 35% devoured by the Plague and will collapse by the day's end. Is there a reason you've changed the subject?"

Cinculu looked at Unarin and smiled. He crossed his arms over his chest. "Contact Matriarch Gorzana. Tell her to connect Grimvolas's Warpgate to the one on XR-Zanovra."

For a moment, the table fell silent.

Founder Cuanali squinted her eyes at Cinculu. "Fifth Founder. Have you lost your mind?"

"Are you unwell?" Founder Treyza asked, his voice taking on a tone of concern. "If you are experiencing suicidal ideations, this one may be able to offer its assistance. There is no need to destroy Grimvolas just to make a point."

"They're right." Unarin said, narrowing his eyes. A hint of disbelief could be seen in them. He had clearly not expected this. "I don't know what you're even thinking, Cinculu, but Kolvaxxed worlds must never activate their warpgates. It could expose their corruption to the world they connect to. If just one Plaguehost makes to to Grimvolas-"

"Quiet." Cinculu said, staring with cold eyes at the First Founder. "You talk too much. Do you think I am stupid? I already know the risks. Those risks do not exist to ones who

truly believe in the power of Dolgris. If you wish to witness salvation, you must take a leap of faith. Now... transmit the order to my Matriarch. She already knew this would happen."

Unarin lowered his eyes. He fell into thought as he quickly assessed what was likely to happen. Clearly, Cinculu was angling for something. But what could it be? Did he actually think he could stand up to the power of the new Kolvaxors? Impossible. Even if this 'Dolgris' was something along the lines of what Unarin assumed, the swarm of Kolvaxians would eventually overpower all. The Middle Cosmic Plaguehosts alone...

Unarin stroked his chin for several seconds before finally closing his eyes.

"Cinculu. If this is an attempt to make me flinch, you have succeeded. Do not place your people in unnecessary harm just to make a point."

"Do it already. The followers of Dolgris know no fear!" Cinculu shouted. "Soon, all of your eyes will be opened. You will know that there are still Truths you have been blind to due to your reliance on heresy!"

Unarin sighed. He realized he wasn't going to win this argument, and at this point... he couldn't help but wonder if there was more than bravado behind Cinculu's words.

"Alright. One moment." Unarin said. "I hope your 'god' can produce a miracle."

He pulled out a transmission device and sent a message to his brother, Randis. Randis in turn relayed that message across the galaxy through quantum entanglement, where it fell upon the ears of the Dolgrimite's Matriarch.

Gorzana stood with fifty other Dolgrimites. When the words passed to her, she grinned, revealing her shiny white teeth.

"XR-Zanovra? A world of water. Good. This will be the perfect staging ground. Activate the warpgate!"

Several minutes passed as the Dolgrimites who had been trained to manage the Warpgate's technology quickly and efficiently keyed in thousands of coordinate calculations. After adjusting for gravitic fluctuations, spatial movement, quantum deviations, and many other interstellar phenomena, they opened the portal.

The world on the other side seemed normal, based purely on what they could see. But distant plumes of dark black smoke rose into the sky. The world seemed to be burning...

"Go!" Gorzana roared. "Move forth and show these nonbelievers the POWER of Dolgris! Enlighten these atheists with the power of our heritage!"

The fifty Dolgrimites roared furiously. They charged into the portal, while Gorzana remained behind. She gazed into the portal, not even bothering to close it in case a Kolvaxian tried to pass through.

"Hehe... try if you like. Don't be shy. *I'll only bite*." Gorzana said, her pupils dilating in hunger.

The next phase of the Kolvaxian War had begun.

Next Part

Part 649: Dolgris Guides Us

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. The water-covered world of XR-Zanovra.

Screams fell upon the ears of the fifty elite Dolgrimite warriors. Their leader was a fierce female named Ursilon, who wore leather skins ripped from the hides of massive exobeasts she had personally hunted. Like all Dolgrimites, she eschewed wielding weapons in favor of unleashing her body's natural killing tools; her claws and teeth. A feral look boiled in her eyes as she hungrily listened to the world around her.

In the distance, down a hill leading away from the Warpgate, waves of unstoppable Kolvaxians smashed into fortified walls built to keep the sea out. As the walls broke, millions of liters of water poured into the nearest city, drowning Technopaths and Changelings alike, allowing the Kolvaxians to swim toward them, snatch their bodies from the floodwaters, then drag them down to the soil below, where they and their victims would disappear, never to be seen in their pure Volgrim forms again.

With the Warpgate up on an elevated hill, it was in no danger of XR-Zanovra's oceans swallowing it, short of a massive tsunami suddenly occurring, but this planet was amazingly stable and earthquakes simply never happened.

A beautiful star hung in the sky, its rays of sunshine warming the planet, contrasting with the unending screams of the helpless Volgrim below.

Ursilon inhaled deeply. Her pupils dilated as she looked up at XR-Zanovra's sun, grinning like a madwoman.

"These Kolvaxians are our prey. But they are formidable. Do not take them lightly. Treat them as the deadly adversaries they are. If any of you fall, you will never escape eternal shame under Dolgris's watchful eyes! Bring glory to His divine name! Show the faithless heathens why our God is the ONE true God!"

The other 49 Dolgrimites raised their fists and roared in unison, the sound sending a small shockwave outward and summoning the attention of countless nearby Kolvaxians. Smelling prey with potent life energies, a massive swarm of more than a thousand Kolvaxians ran, flew, and swam under the soil toward them.

With their true abilities having been revealed during the battle of Maiura, the Plagueborn no longer hid their ability to tap into psionic powers. The only ones that didn't fly were those not directly born of Psion hosts like the rest. But even low-ranking Psiovaxians were terrifying. Their bodies were still as powerful as Executor Huron, and he was a bonafide Low Cosmic with a body matching Middle Cosmics.

Seeing so many faceless monsters known for their planet-cracking strength barreling right at them, any other Sentients would have started quaking in their boots, lost all courage, and bolted.

But not Dolgris's most devout followers. Their battle intent soared. They rushed directly toward the Kolvaxians, spreading out as they split up and traveled in all directions to meet the sphere of bodies engulfing them.

From the Founder's Soul, Unarin and the other Founders watched with rapt attention, utterly silent as several camera drones on XR-Zanovra played the battle for them, live.

They were not the only ones observing. Inside the Spynet Sphere, Fiona, Blinker, and Rebecca took turns watching the camera feeds, their nerves on edge as they wondered what the hell these idiot Dolgrimites were thinking. All of them were mere mortals, and they were fighting creatures with Cosmic bodies. Were they suicidal?!

The tiny defending force of 50 Dolgrimites met the assault force of 1000 Kolvaxians as if they were the ancient Spartans of Earth's legends. Fearless, they collided against the faceless monstrosities, and a brutal melee erupted!

Everything happened so fast, none of the observers could entirely make out what was going on! All they saw was a mess of colored scaled and rotted-green flesh tangling up like a squad of cats all fighting at once. Feral roars erupted as the Dolgrimites started tearing into their enemies.

With her distinctive bone-mask worn over her face, Ursilon stood out from her companions. She grabbed a Kolvaxian and bit onto its neck, ripped out its throat, and swallowed it in one gulp, Her claws raked across its chest, and she crushed it with a bear hug, breaking several of its ribs. At the same time, ten other Kolvaxians punched and scratched at her scales, but for some reason, she didn't even seem to notice their blows, as if they were mere toddlers slapping a brick wall.

Ursilon tore the Kolvaxian apart with frightening savagery, then pounced upon another. A beam of focused psionic energy struck her body and knocked her to the side,

but she stomped her foot and instantly regained her footing, then pounced at the Psiovaxian that had the guts to attack her!

She bit down on its neck and tore its head off, ripping part of the Kolvaxian's spine out as well. She crushed the monster's skull in her mouth and swallowed the bones and brains, licked her lips, and charged at yet another one!

The moment the other Founders realized the Dolgrimites had not instantly lost, but had somehow turned the tables on the previously unstoppable alien monsters, they became shocked out of their wits.

"This-this! How is this possible?!" Cuanali cried out. The Fourth Founder looked at Cinculu with a look of horror, shock, and excitement all at the same time. It had been an eon since she last showed such strong emotion. "This is impossible! Those Dolgrimites are only mortals!"

Cinculu looked at her with the smuggest expression a reptilian possibly could. He folded his claws on the table and smirked. "All is possible when one accepts Dolgris's providence."

Five minutes later, half of the Kolvaxians were dead. Not defeated, not incapacitated and slowly reviving, but truly dead! Any Kolvaxian that fell into the meat grinder of a Dolgrimite's claws and jaws perished and never returned.

It was as if their hardy bodies had turned into soft slabs of tofu. The Kolvaxians silently attacked and pummeled the Dolgrimites, but Dolgris's Chosen shrugged these planet-rumbling punches off with contemptuous ease.

Before long, only 250 Kolvaxians remained. Then only a hundred.

The remaining Kolvaxians finally did something the Founders had never seen before.

They fled!

Some of them dove underground to flee the Dolgrimites' hateful claws.

The Psion-types took to the skies and flew away, racing to get out of range before it was too late!

By the time the few remaining Kolvaxians had dispersed, the blood-covered Dolgrimites had already regrouped. All fifty of them were alive, and none appeared even a little injured!

"Roaaar!!!" Ursilon screamed. "Dolgris guides us! Dolgris protects us! This so-called Plague is nothing but a herd of prey animals before Dolgris's might! Death to the usurpers! Death to those who defame His name!!"

Cinculu watched from the Founder's Soul, more pleased than he had ever been in his entire life. While Treyza remained completely unmoved, as emotionless as ever, it was still clearly surprised by these happenings. Nobody thought the Dolgrimites would crush the Kolvaxians as easily as they did. In fact, nobody thought they would win at all!

"Impressive." Unarin said.

That was all he said. He stared at the holo-image stoically, but Cinculu could tell he was frightened out of his wits. How could he not be? The power of Dolgris was truly overbearing!

After that armada of Kolvaxians had been deterred, Ursilon stabbed a finger toward the village. "Go now! Clear out the rest of these lowly pests! Put the fear of Dolgris into them! Make the parasite's queen know her days are numbered!!"

The Dolgrimites split up into twenty-five groups of two. They charged into the city, with Ursilon joined by a male companion named Pyrakos. True to his name, his scales glowed red with flaming patterns of some sort. A scorching heat boiled beneath his natural armor, causing the gaps between his scales to glow an ominous red.

"My mate. My beautiful mate!" Pyrakos shouted, looking at his lover adoringly. "I pledge to kill twice as many servants of the false god as you!"

"Hah, a pointless boast!" Ursilon exclaimed, meeting his gaze with equal desire. "If you can succeed, I will mate with you and produce another brood! But you had better not let me down!"

"I would never!" Pyrakos retorted. "If I fail, let none call me your mate again!"

Working together, they leaped into the flooded city and swam toward a horde of underwater Kolvaxians without stopping. As reptilian Volgrim who stayed true to their ancient forms, the Dolgrimites were equally adept on land and in sea. In fact, they were even faster and more fierce underwater than above!

They darted around like crocodiles, using their tails to speed up their swimming speed and adjust their direction as they crashed into the underwater Kolvaxian hordes and spilled their green blood into the flooded city for all to see. Before long, the water became

so thick with torn apart body parts, tendons, and Kolvaxian blood that most normal Sentients would be totally lost.

But not the Dolgrimites. They somehow sensed the watery abyss around them and continued hunting the Kolvaxians, crushing their bones and ripping apart their bodies as if they had never been empowered by Artoria in the first place.

Fiona, watching from Chrona, constantly massaged her eyes in wonder. She felt like she was dreaming. How were Dolgris's Devotees so easily able to overpower the previously-thought unstoppable Kolvaxians? She couldn't figure out what the missing puzzle piece was.

The Kolvaxians on XR-Zanovra began to move differently from before. No longer did they mindlessly hunt the remaining life forms. Instead, they started coordinating their movements, locking their senses on the unstoppable Dolgrimites while also trying to keep their distance. The Dolgrimites were extremely fast underwater, and were easily capable of chasing down any Kolvaxians that didn't take to the skies.

But then, Ursilon grabbed her lover, Pyrakos. She and he both stopped their movements and looked down at the soil beneath them.

Their senses tingled a warning. Danger was approaching.

"ORAAAK!" Ursilon shouted, her voice releasing a sonic boom underwater that traveled outward for kilometers in every direction. Like a whale's sonar, it alerted all the other Dolgrimites, and they ceased their pursuit. Like a hivemind, they pivoted in unison and swam toward their leader, arriving beside her within less than twenty seconds.

Ursilon gestured with her claws, and the other Dolgrimites nodded. They quickly swam for the shore, leaped out of the water, and arrived on solid ground, quickly taking up defensive positions.

At once, a trio of Kolvaxors burst from the bloodied, muddied lake behind them and rose into the sky. They were none other than the fallen forms of Executors Nufaris, Huron, and Sartran.

In one way, it was a blessing that Demila had devoured the power of so many elite Psions before killing herself. At the very least, she guaranteed the Kolvaxian scourge could not assimilate Vi, Riley, or Fellrun's powers into itself.

Even so, three Kolvaxors facing down the fifty Dolgrimites made them no longer shout so eagerly. The power radiating from these true Cosmics was enough to make their skin crawl.

"Do not feel fear." Ursilon said solemnly. "Dolgris guides us. Dolgris protects us. These false gods are nothing compared to His power. Alone, we are no match for them, but together, we hold the advantage."

The other Dolgrimites nodded. They did not shout boisterously like before, but instead remained silent as they looked up at the monsters before them.

Kolvaxor Nufaris tilted its faceless head, ever so slightly.

A single word, as chilling as death itself, drifted into the air.

[**DOLGRIS...**]

Ursilon flinched. She took a step back and gasped. "You speak, monster?!"

But the Kolvaxor said nothing else. In an instant, Kolvaxor Huron dove at the Dolgrimites, raised his fist, and punched with enough force to blow open a massive crater in the planet.

Ursilon had no time to react. She simply threw a punch back. When their fists met, her arm snapped backward, and she was pounded down into the dirt, sent dragging along the ground for a quarter of a kilometer!

The leader of the Dolgrimites fainted. The other forty-nine roared and attacked, with Pyrakos leading the charge.

"Remember! Alone, we are weak! But together, we are unstoppable!" Pyrakos roared. "Combine your powers into me! Give no quarter!"

The other Dolgrimites aimed their palms at Pyrakos's back. They began chanting in unison.

"We are Dolgris's Devotees! Our feet sunder the soil! Our claws tear the heavens! Together, we are united!"

Nothing seemed to happen. Pyrakos stupidly charged at Kolvaxor Huron as if he had a death wish, and the Psiovaxian send another punch at him. Pyrakos met this punch with a punch of his own.

When their fists collided, a deafening explosion erupted outward. Sand blasted in all directions. Trees ripped from the soil. Rocks were sent flying! Pyrakos held his ground! Somehow, he matched Huron's strength pound for pound! The two of them erupted into a fury of blows, their fists striking one another all over their bodies, knocking each other back only a little but continuing to rain blows on one another. The other 48 Dolgrimites did nothing but keep their claws aimed at Pyrakos, and to the outside observers, it indeed appeared as if they had somehow passed a part of whatever mystical power each one possessed on to their new temporary leader.

A massive chain snapped down from above. Kolvaxor Sartran transmuted several nearby trees into chains made of iron, then enchanted those chains with the power of thunder. He struck Pyrakos's back when the Dolgrimite's attention was on Huron, and a howl of pain escaped Pyrakos's jowls. At the same time, Kolvaxor Nufaris turned his attention on the other Dolgrimites, who remained immobile.

He rushed at them and sent a powerful gravity wave downward, crushing their bodies into the dirt. Suddenly, Pyrakos's strength dropped noticeably. He started losing in a raw strength matchup to Huron as the links to his comrades weakened.

But among those other Dolgrimites, one of them suddenly gained a huge power boost. A male named Zerravul leaped out of the crowd at Nufaris, taking the Kolvaxor by surprise. Before Nufaris could cancel his gravity attack, the empowered Dolgrimite bit onto his left arm and tugged with all his strength.

Riiiip!

He tore the Kolvaxor's entire arm off, causing blood to gush from the wound. Just like before, the bleeding did not stop, and the Kolvaxian's most fearsome healing ability did not activate. Nufaris seemed to shudder with pain, and his body momentarily froze up. Zerravul took this opportunity to bite onto Nufaris's neck, then yank his head backward.

He tore the Kolvaxor's head off!

Kolvaxor Nufaris perished, leaving only the other two behind.

Even though he had been drastically weakened and was unable to put up a good fight against Huron, Pyrakos still fought like hell, relying more on martial skills than his raw strength. He slithered like an eel, catching his powerful opponent in a head-lock. He tried to tear Huron's skull off his body like Zerravul had just done, but his strength was too

pitiful. Huron turned the tables, pulled the feisty Dolgrimite off him, and hurled him to the side, sending him crashing into several boulders that had not yet been blown away.

Instead of charging at its momentarily stunned adversary, or attacking the other Dolgrimites, Kolvaxor Huron looked left, then he looked right. His faceless head swiveled toward Kolvaxor Sartran, and for a brief instant, it seemed as if the two of them had locked eyes, assuming that was even possible.

Without warning, they darted away, dove underwater, and fled!

Pyrakos picked himself up. He jumped out of the crushed rocks and shook his head to clear away his slightly fuzzy vision. When he looked around, both Kolvaxors were gone!

"Where are they? Where did the false gods go?!" Pyrakos barked.

Zerravul strode over to him and clapped Pyrakos's shoulder. He grinned wickedly.

"They fled! The cowardly false gods fled! After I killed the False Executor, the other two knew they could not win. This is a victory for Dolgris!"

Pyrakos's eyes lit up. "Truly?! Bahaha! So it is! Dolgris guides us! Dolgris overcomes all!"

The Kolvaxors did not return. All the Kolvaxians on the planet slowly dove into the soil and disappeared. Before long, peace fell over XR-Zanovra, a quiet serenity it had not know for more than twenty Terran hours.

Pyrakos found his fallen mate. He roused her from her comatose form and helped her rise to her feet, while she looked around with a mixture of disbelief and devotion. At first she couldn't believe they had defeated such powerful adversaries, but then, she thought, of course they had! How could they not, with Dolgris guiding the hand of fate to favor them?

Millions of XR-Zanovra's Volgrim natives survived the Plague's incursion. They slowly advanced upon the ones who saved them, arriving by many different means. They looked at their saviors with reverence.

"You saved our lives. We owe you countless life debts." One Technopath said. "You accomplished what even the Founders themselves could not. From now on, anything you command, we will obey!"

Despite having taken a severe blow to her ego, Ursilon still remained the leader of Dolgris's Devotees. She stood proudly, her arms crossed and a haughty expression on her

face.

"You have the right attitude! For countless cycles, your people have worshiped the false gods of metal and circuitry! So long as those hideous implants and mutilations scar your body, Dolgris will never accept you! BUT, you may rejoice. If you dispose of them, He will welcome you with open claws. From now on, we shall station a platoon of Dolgris's Devotees on this world! Those of you who wish to abandon the falsities you were taught, you may yet take hold of a glorious future!"

Cheers erupted from the crowd.

"Dolgris saved us! Dolgris is our god! We worship Him! We will give up our evil ways to serve Him!"

The other Dolgrimites looked at each other with expressions of great satisfaction. They had accomplished their goal most marvelously. While Ursilon may have suffered a terrible blow, she did not die, and her injuries could be healed. She had not stained the reputation of Dolgris, so her sins could be forgiven.

Soon, the metal-worshipers would come to see the Truths they had been denied.

Soon, the Plague would realize it had awoken a slumbering horror more awful than itself.

"Dolgris guides us! Dolgris guides us! Glory to His name!"

* * *

Fiona watched the battle on XR-Zanovra with rapt attention. The finale left her gobsmacked, but eventually, she accepted it and began to mentally model what might have happened.

"The Dolgrimites... are able to share power? Uplift themselves to the rank of Cosmic to fight other Cosmics?"

Rebecca shook her head. Even she appeared puzzled. "We did not detect any Cosmic power radiating from them. Whatever means they used to defeat the Kolvaxians, it was not an orthodox method."

Fiona narrowed her eyes. She tapped her lip thoughtfully and looked into the distance.

"Dolgris... who, or *what*, is he?"

Part 650: Unarin's Concession

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. Inside Chrona.

More than a week had passed. A single hour in realspace was equal to nearly 300 in Chrona, and following the operation on XR-Zanovra, Fiona and the other Sentients had spent a lot of time poring over the footage to analyze it.

"The way they combine their powers is so mysterious." Blinker said, as she looked at Rebecca, then at Fiona. "And it seems once they start their ritual, they can quickly transfer power around the group."

"The Dolgrimite power-binding ritual is not so different from the ones Emperor Crow performs." Rebecca added. "Combining the strength of weaker individuals to defeat a stronger one is a niche ability, but effective in certain situations."

"That's the thing though." Fiona countered. "Look at all the readings. Their bodies didn't grow even an iota stronger. Whatever they did, it didn't make them more formidable at battling the Kolvaxians. They were just as strong before and after."

While Fiona talked, she held little baby Timothy in her arms. He made baby babbling noises while she talked, and played with her hair that was hanging down her chest. Sometimes, the cute little boy even tried munching on her hair, but it was mainly a spiritual illusion, so it had no taste or texture.

"They must be weakening the Kolvaxians, then." Blinker proposed. "But... I'm not sure how. Those Dolgrimites have really strong bodies, yet surely a Middle Cosmic like Huron would wipe the floor with them in a fistfight. His strength didn't seem to drop. He punched just as hard as ever. Huron's Kolvax-clone could probably destroy the planet with ease."

Rebecca crossed her arms. She started pacing from side to side inside the Spynet Sphere. She rewound footage of the battle, pointing to the instance when Kolvaxor Nufaris nearly flattened all the Dolgrimites with a gravity attack.

"This was the exact moment when the battle turned in the Dolgrimites' favor." Rebecca analyzed. "The Kolvaxians didn't know how their abilities worked. Nufaris tried to kill the

main Dolgrimite group, but he was caught off-guard when they abruptly bolstered one of their own and he took out the strongest Kolvaxor with a surprise attack."

"I doubt that tactic will work a second time." Blinker responded. "Next time, the Kolvaxians will know about this combined-power and will take measures to counter it."

Fiona appeared unconvinced. "They probably will, but I doubt this is the full extent of the Dolgrimite's power-up. There's something we're missing. If they're weakening the Kolvaxians, how? If we can just figure that much out, we might be able to use this to our advantage."

The other two women fell silent. They looked at each other with uncertainty in their eyes, then they continued to debate for a while longer.

Suddenly, a spark of realization ignited in Fiona's eyes. After several days of thinking and collaborating with the others, her brain lit up with inspiration.

"Oh! I've got it! It all makes sense now! The way the Dolgrimites are able to fight the Kolvaxians is because..."

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. Inside the Founder's Soul.

The Dolgrimite's cleanup operation concluded as a great success. For the first time in the history of the Kolvaxian War, the Volgrim had become the victors. They had driven the Kolvaxians away and saved a world from its clutches.

Where there was one victory of such magnitude, more were likely to follow.

But this victory did not leave four of the Founders with pleasant expressions on their faces. They did not jump for joy or shout in jubilation.

The attitude among them was... muted.

"That was a splendid result." Unarin said calmly, looking Cinculu in the eyes. "Have the Dolgrimites... *always* been able to fight the Plague at this level?"

Cinculu puffed out his chest. "Not always. But for a while, we have."

"Then why did you not volunteer your services sooner?" Cuanali asked, directing a hostile gaze toward him. "We've lost thousands of worlds to the Plague. Tens of thousands! If you could have reversed the course of the war, why didn't you?"

Cinculu sneered. He looked at the metal-clad Technopath Founder with contempt.

"Have you not guessed? We did it to *punish* the heretics in this Empire. Only now that the Psions have fallen did the situation reach an untenable state. Before, it seemed as if you might last another few thousand cycles. But because of your pitiful discipline, your weak minds, and the greed within the hearts of your High Psions, the entire Empire was nearly brought to ruin. Now, the great Dolgris extends a claw to you. It is up to you whether you will cast aside your wicked ways and fall in line... or die while screaming his name."

Cinculu directed his contempt away from Cuanali, toward Unarin.

"What say you now, Unarin? Have you come to regret the path you've chosen? Will you grovel for forgiveness at Dolgris's feet?"

Unarin didn't immediately respond.

He looked across the pentagonal table at Cinculu, seemingly falling deep into thought.

"I did not entirely expect the situation to develop in this direction." Unarin eventually said. "But you've been acting so self-assured for so long a time, I assumed you must have had some hidden secret at your disposal. You've actually managed to surprise me a little."

Unarin leaned back in his chair. He rested his palms in his lap and sighed.

"You now hold the key to the Volgrim Empire's future life and death, Cinculu. I could be obstinate and continue with the Dying Light Initiative, but that would only result in the deaths of 99% of all remaining Volgrim. Clearly, this is no longer necessary. What must I do to secure Dolgris's help?"

Cinculu's smirk turned into a vicious grin.

"Need you even ask? Step down as First Founder. Retire and live your life in peace. I will take over in Dolgris's name, and lead our people to a future free of heresy."

"Alright." Unarin immediately said. "Done. You are now the First Founder. Anything else?"

Cinculu coughed.

He damn near choked on his own spit. He looked at Unarin for a moment, shocked out of his wits.

"W-what? That's it?"

Unarin shrugged. "I have ruled for a long time. If you think you can do better than me, and if it will save the lives of our people, then I can at least do this much. If your only goal was to seize control of the Volgrim Empire, you could have put this plan into motion a long time ago and saved more lives. It's a shame you didn't, but there is no room in my soul for condemnation now."

Cinculu balked. He couldn't believe what he was hearing.

Unarin was willing to give up the seat of the First Founder to him? Just like that?! Wasn't this a little too easy?

Cinculu became suspicious. Unarin was known for his mind-games. He was a cerebral leader first and foremost. He might be laying a trap for the admittedly slower-witted Dolgrimite.

"What tricks are you dreaming up?" Cinculu asked, narrowing his eyes in suspicion.

Unarin shrugged innocently. "No tricks. The Psions are all but dead. It will take time, precious time we cannot afford, to raise them back to their previous heights. I have ruled for a long, long time. The Empire nearly fell because of my inadequacy. Clearly, whoever Dolgris is, he has given you power I cannot contend with."

Unarin lowered his eyes, seeming to appear a little sad.

"It's a shame this is how it ends, but I am not a petty Volborn. I have failed my people, and it is only right that I step aside."

He paused, then lifted his eyes to direct a strange look at Cinculu.

"Although... I do wonder... are you ready to handle the management of our Empire?"

Cinculu's heart turned cold. The look Unarin was giving him made him feel small in a way he couldn't quite describe.

"Of... of course I am." Cinculu said haltingly. "What are you implying?"

Unarin lifted his head and sighed dramatically. "Ohh, it's just... after I step down, it will be up to you to either convince all the Volgrim currently managing the Empire to follow your lead, or to put new ones in their places. The Volgrim Star Empire consists of more than 1,000,000 free worlds, not counting the hundreds of thousands that have fallen to the Plague in the past. With Dolgris's power, you will naturally work to liberate those worlds and take them back, but this only *expands* the problem I mentioned previously."

Unarin clicked his tongue chidingly.

"So many worlds... how much administrative support do you think you'll need, keeping them all placated and under your control? The Volgrim people have only known me as their leader. They cannot imagine anyone else. Why, I imagine you're going to have quite the time convincing them to follow you, or Dolgris, or whoever as their new First Founder. Are you sure you're... *up to the challenge?*"

Cinculu shifted in his chair. He subtly glanced back at Virile, who remained standing in place, unmoving, not daring to say a word in this battle between heavyweights.

Cinculu returned his attention back to Unarin. "So that's your trap. You will pass power to me in name, but foment rebellion, making the worlds unable to accept me as their leader! Truly a nasty trick, Unarin."

Unarin scoffed. He crossed his arms and looked at Cinculu with a smirk. "Don't be a fool, Cinculu. I need not stoop that low. I will happily step aside and watch you burn the Empire which was already going to perish anyway. If you think you can do a better job than me, go right ahead. Take control. Find out just how much I do as leader of our people. I only worry you will find the job is neither as *simple* nor as *fun* as you believe it to be."

Silence fell over the room. Cinculu felt his stomach churning. He had expected Unarin to put up a fight, to beg to keep his title, to bow at Dolgris's feet, or to try and struggle for relevancy.

But Cinculu did not expect Unarin to instead riddle him with words of logic.

The truth was, Cinculu did not especially covet the power of First Founder. What good would it do him to move up the ranks and rule the Volgrim Empire? He was already one of the Five Founders, a being so far above the unwashed masses that they would bow and grovel at his feet wherever he went. Certainly, Unarin was considered a step above the other four, but Cinculu was often considered to be equal in status to Cuanali, Treyza, and even Dosena. The four of them were tied for second place in the hearts of their subjects, and that was a fine place to be.

Cinculu wasn't entirely sure what it would mean to run and manage the daily operations of the Volgrim Empire. He hadn't even given it much thought. But now that Unarin put him on the spot, Cinculu realized... it couldn't possibly be easy!

Unarin was right. He wouldn't have to lift a finger for rebellion to explode across every Volgrim-colonized world. How could they possibly accept Cinculu as their First Founder? He would be seen as a usurper and a scumbag who betrayed the other Founders!

Right now, Cinculu knew he was respected and feared across the Milky Way. But if he truly took the next step and seized power, all his respect would turn to smoke. He would still be feared, but for different reasons entirely.

A snarl formed at the edges of Cinculu's mouth. "You... tricky creature. What are you angling for?"

Unarin finally stopped smiling. He sat forward and rested his arms on the table.

"Alright. I'll be direct. I don't necessarily love spending every waking minute of my life running this Empire, but it's something I've grown comfortable doing. I have an eon of experience, and changing leadership right now would throw the galaxy into chaos."

Unarin narrowed his eyes and pointed a finger at Cinculu.

"If, through Dolgris, we now have the means to fight back and defeat the Plague, then you know as well as I do what our *true* goal should be. This civil war? It means nothing. Someday, if we do manage to crush the Kolvaxians and subjugate the other Sentients, we will still have the Akashic War to deal with. Are you certain Dolgris alone is capable of handling this matter?"

Cinculu glared at Unarin. "You dare speak ill of our God?"

"Do not play at being a fool, Cinculu." Unarin said sternly. "I know for a fact you would make a terrible leader for the Volgrim. You are not strong-willed enough, you lack the clout to make everyone fall into line, and frankly your heart is not interested in ruling over anyone. All you really want are deep concessions for the Dolgrimites, and that is something I am plenty willing to agree to."

Unarin paused.

"You might not make for a good First Founder, but you are also not an imbecile. You know just as well as I do the Truth about Dolgris. He is not a 'god'. You cannot be so delusional as to actually believe in such a thing when you have observed the same Truths as your fellow Founders."

Virile and Ravagil glowered at Unarin. The hateful, heretic words he was spouting made them want to tear his head off. The bastard! How dare he defame their God?!

But Cinculu actually started to calm down. He looked at Unarin while ignoring the sensation of his fellow Dolgrimites gazing at the back of his head.

Unarin knows more than he's let on. How long has he known? Has he only had suspicions until now? Cinculu wondered.

"Speak plainly." Cinculu growled.

"Alright. Let's see if I can avoid making a fool of myself." Unarin said. "Your so-called 'God' is not a God at all. He is a Sentient. A *very* powerful Sentient. He has hidden his power for ages. I'm not entirely certain of all the details, but perhaps he might even be..."

Unarin paused.

"...an *Apex Cosmic?*"

Cinculu's heart skipped a beat. He tried not to let his shock show, but Unarin clearly noticed all the microscopic details on the Fifth Founder's face. He could not hide his emotions nearly as well as Unarin.

"It seems I've guessed correctly." Unarin said. "I actually suspected he might only be a High Cosmic, but based on your reaction..."

"You!!" Cinculu roared, pounding the table. "Confounding bastard!"

Before he could say anything else, Unarin interjected. "And let me hazard another guess. That little stunt on XR-Zanovra? Each Dolgrimite you sent was an Apex Mortal. None of them were Cosmics. Yet, even as mere mortals, they were able to challenge those monstrously powerful Kolvaxors. How could such a thing be possible, I wonder? It certainly makes sense if your 'God' is an Apex Cosmic."

Unarin lifted his chin. "Your bodies are not ordinary. Each Dolgrimite is able to project an energy field that stifles other beings you come into close contact with. This power belongs not to you, but to Dolgris. By combining your energy, you are able to channel it into a smaller number of hosts, drastically empowering its effectiveness."

"Finally, and perhaps most importantly," Unarin concluded, "this field of energy is able to stifle the Kolvaxors precisely because of Dolgris's status as an Apex Cosmic. He is mighty enough that even a few slivers of his energy will crush the strength of weaker Cosmics."

All three Dolgrimites looked at Unarin in horror. They felt as if their scales had been stripped away, leaving them naked before his gaze.

What monstrous deductive power! All this from a few clues and watching the battle unfold live? And he had figured it all out in less than an hour! No... more likely, he'd had plenty of suspicions and guesses over the past several thousand years and only now managed to combine it all together into a cohesive deduction.

But even so! This was unbelievable. The Dolgrimites could not wrap their heads around just how scary Unarin's brain could be.

If Cinculu and the others held any thoughts that they would be better than Unarin in terms of wisdom and ruling an Empire, those beliefs were left thoroughly crushed.

"You... are remarkably insightful." Cinculu said through gritted teeth after a few moments.

"Using the power of many to subdue a greater adversary is not too novel of an innovation." Unarin countered. "The Demons have done it, and the Psions, too. Dolgris's ability is, at the least, much more potent than the previous examples."

Unarin's presence seemed to diminish. He knocked lightly on the table, then cleared his throat.

"Would you mind if I made a proposal, Cinculu?"

The Dolgrimite leader hesitated. He couldn't help but be a little afraid of what Unarin said next. Would he start guessing every other secret the Dolgrimites thought was secure?

But, he relented. "Go on."

"Alright. Here it is then." Unarin said, spreading his palms apart graciously. "I will stay the First Founder. Our Empire will remain as it is now. However, I will only be a figurehead. Dolgris, in his capacity as an Apex Cosmic, will be the one who truly leads the Empire. If he wishes to issue any edicts, I will deliver them and comply with all his orders. If he wishes to kill me, he can do so as well. I shall follow any commands he gives. And you, as his spokesperson, will be the go-between for both of us. A most prestigious role, I might add."

"You're saying you would willingly bend the knee to Dolgris? All this just to retain your power?" Cinculu asked. "Are you truly so shameless?"

"How little you know." Unarin replied, his tone bland. "I have spent millions of cycles building this Empire. I enjoy watching it grow, watching it thrive. If you think I only do this for some self-aggrandizing reason, then let me assure you, I do not."

Unarin waved his hand flippantly.

"I would love to step back and let someone else lead. I would love to take a vacation and tour the galaxy, observe various civilizations, gaze upon their art and culture, and immerse myself in frivilous pleasantries. But I cannot bring myself to do so if it would mean placing the future of my people in the hands of incompetent buffoons. Until someone who I consider to be my intellectual equal rises up and shows the desire and capacity to continue leading our great Empire, I will do what I can to remain in power and keep the galaxy... stable."

He lowered his hand.

"So, that is why I make this arrangement. It has nothing to do with my ego. I only want to see our people thrive. Everything I do is to achieve that end."

Unarin fell silent. Cinculu became thoughtful. His hostility dropped somewhat, and he gazed at the table, uncertain of what to do.

But it wasn't long before he decided to speak.

"You are effectively asking me to maintain the status quo." Cinculu muttered. "That would defeat the purpose of today's demonstration."

"On the contrary. You have demonstrated that the Dolgrimites are capable of playing an extremely useful role in our Empire. No longer sidelined, mocked, or ignored, you will become the future protectors of our people, granted the same prestige the Psions once held." Unarin replied smoothly. "I am certain that as time goes on, many Volgrim will convert to worshiping Dolgris. They will bow before his might, as demonstrated by his devotees. This is what you want, yes?"

"It is... but will you feel satisfied knowing our people no longer worship *you*?" Cinculu asked.

"I have never demanded, asked, nor implicitly made it seem as though I desired our people's adoration." Unarin replied. "This Empire is vast. It is bigger than perhaps you are even capable of comprehending. I have taken on the role of a figurehead out of necessity. It is important the Volgrim have a unifying figure at the top. Whether it be me or Dolgris, I care not. I am content with sinking back into the shadows and working in secret. As Dolgris grows to swallow more of the people's attention, I will be more free to move about and pursue my own hobbies and desires."

That answer seemed to satisfy Cinculu.

"Very well. I will convey your intentions to Dolgris."

Unarin paused.

"Ah, about that. It will not be necessary. You will arrange for me to meet with Dolgris in person."

"WHAT?!" Cinculu roared, standing up and throwing his seat aside in a fit of rage. "No! How dare you?! I will never allow it!!"

The table fell silent. The other four Founders looked at Cinculu with mixed expressions, some of them pitiable, some of them mocking. Only Treyza seemed utterly unmoved, its neutral expression never changing in the least.

"We've been over this." Unarin said, completely disregarding the fearsome look on Cinculu's face. It was as if he were being threatened by a clown. "You may think of Dolgris as a god, but in the end, he is a Sentient like any other. I will speak to him alone, in person, with no others present. I will naturally be at his mercy, and if he should so desire to execute my for my impudence, nobody will retaliate."

Cinculu shook with rage. In his mind, he knew Dolgris was not really a god, but his heart had long ago turned to stone and would never allow such blasphemy to be spoken! It took all his self control not to leap across the table and bite Unarin's throat out!

Dosena was no longer a threat. Unarin was totally defenseless! Yet even now, Cinculu simply couldn't bring himself to make such a move. It was as if his wrists had been shackled by the rules of a game he did not know he was even playing.

He shook with hatred for several seconds, then slowly blinked his eyes.

"You... I will inform Dolgris of your... *request*. If my God decides to grant you an audience, it will be on his prerogative. *Not yours*."

Unarin seemed as if he might argue the point, but sensing Cinculu's religious fervor, he decided not to press his luck.

"Very well. We'll do it that way, then. I look forward to Dolgris's response."

With his seat thrown aside, Cinculu decided it would not be fitting for him to pick it up and sit back down like a doofus. So, instead, he swept his gaze around the table in a manner most grandiose.

"Treyza. The rest of you. I take my leave."

Without another word, he spun on his heel and stormed out, the other two Dolgrimites right behind him.

After Muuxunuu had opened and shut the door to the Founder's Soul, a full minute of silence followed. None of the other four Founders said a word.

Then, Cuanali broke the silence.

"Everything was as you predicted." She said, closing her eyes and bowing her head.

"Almost everything." Treyza interjected. "Founder Unarin did not predict that the Dolgrimites would defeat the Kolvaxors. He predicted that Dolgris himself would intervene."

"A minor discrepancy." Unarin said, smiling at the other Founders. "We have preserved our power... for now. Although, I do find it... curious."

"Find what curious?" Cuanali asked, her robotic tone rising an octave.

"If Dolgris is so powerful, then why does he need to rely on mere mortals to fight his battles for him?" Unarin mused. "Something tells me this ancient entity is not what he seems. I... *look forward* to speaking with him in person."

"The Dolgrimites are zealots. They will not grant you an audience." Treyza stated.

Unarin sneered.

"It won't be up to *them*."

Part 651: Rebuilding

Far-Future Era. Day 3, AJR.

Across the Milky Way, the recent shocking events continued to compound and explode out of control. Between the fall of Maiura, the destruction of Tarus II, the betrayal of Demila, the fall of the Psions, and now, the reveal of the Dolgrimites... far too much had happened in only three days!

The rumors were spreading faster than a Kolvaxian infection! Humans, demons, and Volgrim alike were struggling to keep up with one explosive story after another! In fact, almost nobody knew about what had happened on XL-Zanovra outside the Volgrim survivors, the Dolgrimites, and Chrona's spies.

For once, the demons were completely unaware. Due to the remote location of XL-Zanovra and the fact no Cosmics were involved, outside the Kolvaxors who were already known for appearing and disappearing across the galaxy, the Demon Deities had no clue about what had just transpired.

Thus, a day later, when Demon Deity Auger was preparing for the demons' new transition to supporting the humans in hopes of countering the Kolvaxians, he was startled when a one of his Dukes arrived at his manor on Numaria.

Dawn, the Demon Duke of Stillness, quickly bowed her head and dropped to one knee as she entered his abode.

"Deity Au-ger! I have news to de-liver! The Warpgate on Numaria has just opened up. A vi-sitor is here. Says he is a Dol-grimite from the world of Grimvolas. He requests an urgent meeting with you!"

The cute young vampiress lifted her head and smiled, baring her fangs at Auger. She was none other than the former Lord of Caves who had long ago interacted with Amelia around the same time as her encounter with Gressil. But now, after dutifully serving under the Deities and absorbing Emperor Glinch's blood-essence-pills, she, and many other formerly weak Demon Lords, had been uplifted to ever greater heights! So many demons had been uplifted that Glinch had actually run out of pills. She, and those like her, could advance no further.

Auger frowned. "A Dolgrimite?"

Dawn nodded quickly. "Yes, Deity! He says he has a report to de-liver regarding the Kolvaxians."

Auger nodded. "Send him in, then leave us."

Dawn did as she was told. Thirty minutes later, a hunched-over Dolgrimite strode into the room, bowing his head respectfully, but without fear, in deference to the Demon Deity.

"Auger. My mother wishes she could have come. Unfortunately, her duties to Dolgris take precedence over all other matters."

"Yes. *Dolgris*." Auger said, narrowing his eyes slightly. "Founder Cinculu. I am always pleased to meet with one such as yourself, but given the recent events that have transpired in Volgrim space, I am surprised Unarin himself did not pay me a visit."

Cinculu raised his head. He smirked at the Demon Deity of Civilizations.

"Hehehe... it seems you are unaware of what has transpired."

"I am quite aware." Auger replied, his tone bland. "The Psions have fallen. Your Empire is crumbling. Now, you come to me, hoping to fall beneath my protective wing."

A moment of silence followed. Auger frowned when he saw Cinculu's unchanged expression.

"No, dear Auger, you *are* unaware." Cinculu repeated. "A great many happenings have transpired. The old balance of power no longer remains relevant. A new change in rulership has taken over the Milky Way. Soon, all will bow their heads before the might of Dolgris. I am not here as a representative of the Founders."

Auger's frown deepened. "...Then why have you come?"

"You species is vulnerable. You are frail and weak." Cinculu said. "The Psions will no longer hold back the Plague. Soon, give or take a few rotational cycles, it is likely the Plague will come to you. And you have *no* adequate means to protect yourself. You will fall... no matter how many units of time must pass before the inevitable conclusion."

The Deity of Civilizations snorted. "That's funny, coming from a Volgrim. If the demons ultimately fall, it will be long after your people do. Things aren't looking so good for you."

"You still are not paying attention to my hints." Cinculu said with a quiet sigh. "Never the matter. I'll make it more obvious."

He stood up a little straighter. His body towered more than three feet above Auger, but as a mere mortal, his presence was weaker.

Even so, he still felt... oddly formidable.

"Dolgris's Devotees are not helpless against the so-called Plague." Cinculu said, his tone grave. "In fact, we are its worst enemy. We have taken back a world which was about to fall to the Plague. XR-Zanovra now belongs to Dolgris."

"What?" Auger asked, momentarily tongue-tied. "You have a method?"

"*Of course*." Cinculu said with a feral grin. "We are the predator, and the Kolvaxians are our prey. Dolgris sees all. Dolgris knows all. Those who bend the knee will share in His glory. Those who defy Him will burst apart like bugs beneath a heel."

Auger's heart skipped a beat. He couldn't tell if Cinculu was bullshitting him or not. But if it was a lie, it was a bold one. It shouldn't be too hard to validate what he was saying!

"What happened on XR-Zanovra?" Auger asked.

"You won't take me at my word? No matter. I've brought a Recording Crystal. All shall be revealed." Cinculu replied, extending his claw to reveal a small purple gem.

Auger fell silent. He retrieved the crystal, then poured his mana into it. A scene began to play for him, a perfect re-enactment of the battle between the Dolgrimites and the Kolvaxians, taken from one of the Dolgrimite warriors' point of view.

Several minutes passed. Half an hour. A full hour.

Both males remained silent. Cinculu stared reverently at the video, mentally basking in the power displayed by his brothers and sister. Auger stared, his mouth slightly agape, shocked out of his wits.

The Dolgrimites didn't just win, they absolutely crushed the enemies even Diablo would have struggled to defeat. In fact, Diablo had no chance. Once the Empowered Kolvaxians appeared, he was utterly helpless. He died the very same day Artoria had Uplifted them.

Now, it seemed the Dolgrimites were able to stomp Diablo's previous feat into the ground. They weren't simply strong, they were *terrifying*.

After playing back the entire video, the crystal broke into dust. It had perfectly recreated the battle, but it could only be used once. Luckily, the Dolgrimites were capable of making more.

Despite finishing the video, Auger did not immediately speak. He stared off into the distance, his mind ablaze.

The Dolgrimites can fight back and defeat the Plague. We cannot. That gives them an unbeatable advantage. If they choose to do nothing, the rest of the Milky Way will fall. Then they can fight back and reclaim it. But if so, why come to me? The math doesn't add up. They must see some value in working with the demons.

Perhaps there is a numerical disparity. The Dolgrimites can certainly crush the Kolvaxians, but their people only populate a single world. Compared to the tens of trillions, perhaps even septillions of Kolvaxians, their numbers are far, far too few. They might want to build up a relationship with the demons to use us as meatshields. Or perhaps though they are strong against the Kolvaxians, they are not so strong against other Threats.

And then there is the matter of Dolgris...

Auger massaged his hand against his chin, stroking his goatee thoughtfully. He looked at Cinculu with deep suspicion.

"You have no need of my people. Why come here? Simply to brag? You can win this war by staying back, allowing the Plague to devour us all, and then slaughtering it after the fact."

Cinculu crossed his arms and puffed out his chest.

"The Auger I know would not say something so foolish. We have the absolute advantage in strength, but the disadvantage in numbers. If the Plague should attack with its full force, it might crash upon our people relentlessly, cycle after cycle, beating and wearing us down until we perish to the last Sentient. Thus, we have... special needs."

Auger decided to voice his misgivings. "You mean bodies for the meat grinder."

Cinculu stayed quiet for a moment. He closed his eyes and bowed his head.

"You demons are not so different from us Dolgrimites."

"In what way?" Auger asked.

"You detest technology. You eschew the embrace of metal while staying true to your origins. Your bodies are more volatile than ours, more prone to strange mutations, likely as a result of your reliance of devouring souls... but at your core, you are a species that holds certain principles dear."

Cinculu raised his head. He opened his eyes and extended his claw with its palm facing up.

"We intend to convert some of the Volgrim who are not entirely lost. We will make them see the light and return to Dolgris where they belong. But the vast majority are lost. They hide in their star vessels, praying to the false gods for salvation. They may be false believers, but they are also our greatest threat. We only possess a few star vessels; necessary for defending our voidspace, but disgusting to us by all accounts, and built by the worshipers of steel and circuits. Full of security holes. Not to be trusted."

He crooked a finger and waggled it at Auger.

"That is where your species comes in. Once this war is over, we will need trustworthy allies; ones who share our vision of a united galaxy, capable of battling the Threats which shall surely come afterward. We will need your help to eliminate our heretic brothers and sisters, seize control of their wealthy worlds, and rebuild them in Dolgris' honor."

"Let's say we succeed." Auger said, his face betraying neither interest nor disinterest in Cinculu's offer. "Let's say we purge the galaxy of the Plague, of the 'heretics' you cannot defeat alone... where does that leave the Demons and Dolgrimites? Will we continue to be allies? Or don't you think we will start to fight among each other?"

"Right now, survival should be our only goal." Cinculu responded. "There is plenty of galaxy to split between our species. Millions of life-bearing worlds. We can always satiate our greed far, far in the future."

A long pause followed. Auger turned away. He wandered off to the left and stared out at the beautiful sunny forest canopy beyond his halls with a grim and thoughtful look.

"A matter this important... I cannot decide it on my own."

Cinculu chuckled. "If you accept, my people shall position at least three regiments of elite Dolgrimite warriors on any worlds you deem core to your cause. For the lesser

worlds, we will place two regiments, and on the least important worlds, only one. If the Plague should ever attack, your worlds will have their safety assured."

"That's generous of you." Auger said, directing a cold eye toward Cinculu. "That's *very* generous."

"You suspect I have ulterior motives?" Cinculu asked.

"I know you do." Auger replied. "This is simply all so sudden that I haven't had time to determine what they might be."

He stroked his goatee once more.

"If you truly want to secure an alliance with my people, then I need more information. I need to know... who Dolgris is. If your 'god' is not some ephemeral figure, but a flesh and blood entity, than securing demonkind's alliance will not happen without my meeting him in person."

Cinculu's expression darkened. "You? A mere Middle Cosmic? You believe yourself worthy of entering His presence? It seems Dolgris's name does not command the respect it should. Even Unarin had the guts to request an audience..."

"How can I possibly respect someone I don't even know?" Auger asked, trying not to look annoyed. "If your 'god' does not exist anywhere but your imagination, then just say so and stop wasting our time. If he does, then arrange a meeting. I am leader of the Demons. If I cannot request an audience, then who can? You should at least show some sincerity."

Cinculu eyed Auger carefully. A full minute passed as he mulled Auger's demands in his mind.

"I will speak to Dolgris. I will convey your wishes to His Eminence."

"Good." Auger said. "I don't see any reason we need to speak further. I should call up the other Demon leaders first and tell them about the new *new* situation. I will need their consent before entering our species into any binding pledges."

Cinculu slowly nodded. "Let us speak again, Auger."

"Cinculu." Auger replied, his tone terse.

The Fifth Founder turned on his heel, then marched out of Auger's Sanctum and left.

Minutes passed.

Auger became thoughtful. He debated a great many possibilities in the back of his mind.

The Deity of Civilizations was not an intellectual genius like Unarin, nor did he have an accelerated brain like Dosena, but he was quick-witted in his own way. Being able to trade around the powers of millions of demons necessarily meant he could tap into the minds of his subjects at will. He had become quite adept at bending others to his will via manipulation and deception.

Now that he had become the de facto 'First Emperor of Demonkind', such tricks were not strictly necessary... though it rankled him that a certain other usurper continued to hold the title.

Auger closed his eyes.

[Yardrat. Convene the other Deities. The situation has changed... *again*.]

With three days having passed since the fall of Tarus II, the humans that scattered to the worlds of Pixiv and Sharmur slowly came to grips with their new reality. Their lives had been completely upended. Fathers, mothers, sons and daughters had perished, leaving countless families broken beyond repair. Many people numbly trudged through their day to day lives, working to build new housing, all while wondering in the backs of their minds just how long it would be until their *new* reality fell apart again.

Nobody had any confidence in the status quo being maintained. They trudged along like zombies, doing what was told, but not really investing their energy into anything.

The mood was somber. Soleil sat up in a tree outside the vicinity of the first major human city in the former Sharmur capital. Below her, a large open stone arena stood, and a pair of women were fighting one another. One of them wielded a sword and a shield, the other used her flexible limbs that could change shape into whatever she needed.

These two were Cassiel and Belial.

Under the cover of a stealth field put down by one of Belial's Demon Duke contacts, the two women sparred with furious gusto. Time was not on their side. They needed to spend every possible day training their bodies and minds. Cassiel had assumed her true angelic form under the cover of the stealth field, and used her wings to accelerate her movement with the instinctive knowledge she had built up ages ago.

Belial wasn't really in need of the training, but it was still good for her. It helped clear her head.

Cassiel, on the other hand, was badly out of practice, a hundred thousand years rusty, and had suffered horrendous psychological trauma.

Whenever Belial charged at her, Cassiel flinched slightly. She knew Belial wouldn't deliberately try to kill her, but her body's reaction was instinctual. She could not control her involuntary muscle reactions any more easily than she could control Sharmur's winds.

Belial's fists crashed against Cassiel's shield. Cassiel stabbed at her training partner, and Belial dodged the attack with a fluid sidestep.

"Your movements are sloppy." Belial said between blows. "If you were a fearsome fighter in the past, you're not anymore. You have a long way to go before you reach your previous heights."

Cassiel gritted her teeth. "Quiet, you! I won't give up!"

She charged at Belial and tried to slam her shield into the Demon Emperor's arm, but Belial slithered downward, ducked under the shield, and swept her leg out, tripping Cassiel and sending her collapsing to the dirt atop her shield. A gruesome crackling noise made Belial's heart drop.

"Argh! My wrist, ahhh!" Cassiel cried out.

Due to the way she was holding the shield, it had suddenly snapped her wrist when she collapsed on top of it, leaving bones sticking out.

Belial grimaced. She quickly dropped to one knee, then helped pull Cassiel's hand out of the shield's holster. Using her healing magic, she repaired the damage, then paused to touch the angel's back.

"I'm sorry. We can stop if you need a break. I've been going pretty hard on you."

Cassiel clenched her jaw. She flopped onto her butt and stared gloomily into the distance while gently massaging her wrist. Even though the wound had been healed, the phantom pain remained. It still seemed as if she could feel her bones jabbing up through the skin.

"We can't stop." Cassiel whispered. "It's only a small injury. Already as good as new."

Suddenly, a voice called out from above. "Someone is coming."

It was Soleil, who was there to keep a lookout for unwanted visitors. With her warning, Cassiel quickly grasped the Heaven's Shroud and activated it, returning back to her human persona within seconds.

Less than a minute later, a male voice became audible at the edge of the clearing as he passed through the stealth field.

"What's this? Some sort of barrier?"

"Melody said she'd be here..." A female voice said, her tone tinged with doubt.

They crested the top of a small hill and stepped into the arena, finally becoming visible.

"B-Beelzebub?" Belial exclaimed. "And Kiari?"

"Oh, hey, Belial." Beelzebub said, giving her a half-hearted wave. "I came to get your help. See, me and Kiari- hm?"

He paused, noticing the random human woman wearing armor, wielding a sword in one hand while a shield with flakes of blood lay on the ground.

"...Am I interrupting something?" Beelzebub asked.

"Nothing I'd consider your business." Belial gruffly answered. "I heard you 'Ascended.' Became a Middle Cosmic. The other Deities may or may not have lightly shat their pants at the thought of you attacking them."

Beelzebub looked at the random human woman for only a moment before immediately ignoring her. For all he knew, she was Belial's 'partner' and this was some sort of odd copulation ritual. Rumor had it Belial wasn't really into males these days, so it wasn't out of the ordinary. And he didn't give a damn about some ordinary human woman anyway.

Beelzebub jerked a thumb toward Kiari. "You remember Kiari's husband?"

Belial nodded. "Saul, yes. What's wrong? Has something happened?"

Kiari's expression darkened. "Beelzebub has been helping me... look for Saul... we've looked... we've looked everywhere. I'm at my wit's end. I was teleported off Tarus II, but... but... I don't know if..."

The arena fell silent. Belial lowered her eyes.

"As a Demon Emperor, it's likely you were deemed a high value asset. Your survival was essential. But with the Volgrim attacking so quickly and so brutally... Saul might not have received the same treatment. Other VIPs would have come before him."

Kiari's expression didn't change. She looked as dead inside as ever. "Please... please don't say that. Can you think of anywhere he might be, Samantha?"

Belial continued to look at the ground.

She didn't know for sure... but the answer seemed obvious.

Saul was dead. He had to be.

He wasn't a high value asset. He would have been considered mid-value at best. Many others were more necessary to save than him.

Belial had lost a husband. She knew the agony Kiari must be experiencing. Even if Kiari and Saul had only known each other for a tiny fraction of how long Satan and Belial did, their bond was just as beautiful.

She swallowed a heavy lump in her throat.

"There's... there might be... one other place you could look." Belial finally said, after a few seconds of thinking. "The Hall of Heroes, Hope's secret domain."

"Oh? Why there?" Beelzebub asked.

"Because Saul was Solomon's nephew." Belial explained. "And he worked closely with Hope... until the Second Wordsmith died. It's the only place I can think of that makes sense. Maybe they teleported Saul off-world before..."

"Yes. You might be right." Beelzebub said. "Do you have any idea how we can contact the Hall of Heroes?"

"Your best bet is to find one of Jepthath's Legionnaires." Belial said, before visibly cringing. "But. Um. You're both... *demons*. They don't... like us."

Kiari's expression fell. "No. No they don't. Is there anyone else?"

Belial scratched her head.

"I wasn't exactly on speaking terms with anyone related to Hope. He was a bit of a bastard toward me. Though, if I had to hazard a guess... Neil Adams is gone, Hope is gone... oh!"

Belial raised a finger and smiled. "There is one person who's not a complete and total piece of work. Why don't you look for Neil's assistant, Debra? If she's still alive, she might be able to act as an intermediary for you. She could pass your request along the grapevine, through the Legion."

Beelzebub looked puzzled. He hadn't the slightest idea who Debra was, but Kiari seemed to know. She mostly got along with everyone, as long as they weren't diehard anti-demon fanatics.

"Debra!" Kiari exclaimed, smiling more cheerfully than before. "That's a great idea. Okay, thanks for the tip, Sammy! We appreciate it."

Beelzebub nodded. "We'll let you and your girlfriend get back to scissoring."

He and Kiari turned to walk away, while Belial was left frowning at his backside.

Cassiel turned beet-red. "H-hey! What is that pig implying?!"

"It's best not to ask." Belial said.

In the back of her mind, Belial felt extremely puzzled.

Beelzebub doesn't feel like a Demon Deity. He seems pretty normal. Why can't I sense any of the power from him that I do from the other Deities?

She shook her head, then turned to face Cassiel once more.

"Now that those two are gone, would you like to continue training?"

Cassiel nodded. She returned to her angelic form and gritted her teeth.

"We've only just begun!"

Part 652: Beelzebub's Bluff

Far-Future Era. Day 3, AJR. The world of Sharmur.

Beelzebub and Kiari traveled into Sharmur's capital city, which was also the only city where any Sentients had assembled. In the past, before the Kolvaxians attacked, hundreds of millions of demons and a few million humans had lived spread across the planet, but now only a comparatively tiny number lived here.

Following the rebirth of the planet, the capital city had been renamed to Melodia, after their planet's highest protector. Located nearest the Great Temple where the planet's sole Warpgate was located, Melodia had only existed for two days, but already it had become a hubbub of activity.

Humans and demons swarmed over the city. Melodia had only fallen for a short period of time after the Kolvaxians took over, yet it and every other city had become overgrown with new trees, vines, and other foliage swallowing the buildings whole. Many parts of Sharmur that were once barren and lifeless deserts had already started turning into lush gardens, and locations that had a decent amount of greenery turned into veritable jungles. As for the areas which were already dense, those became far thicker and taller than any others.

It was clear to anyone with half a brain that the Kolvaxian takeover had stimulated the life energy of the planet, causing its foliage to explode in density.

Beelzebub and Kiari took their time. They weren't in a big rush. They wandered through the streets, looking at various humans and demons working alongside monsters to clear out buildings along the main dirt road.

"We've already looked in so many places." Kiari said anxiously. "What... what if Saul isn't inside the Hall of Heroes? What if he...?"

Beelzebub pursed his lips. "There's a very real likelihood... well... you should prepare yourself. It's awful to imagine, but different lives are valued differently by the higher-ups."

Kiari's stomach knotted together. She massaged her nascent womb, still not entirely sure how to feel about the fact that, as a demon, she had become pregnant. She had never

anticipated this happening, and it was only a happy coincidence. But now, her husband might be gone. She wasn't ready for the heartache.

"Humans are... so fragile." Beelzebub mused. "Their lives are fleeting. They live for a while, and then they die. Not like demons, angels, or many monsters. They accomplish incredible things... then they're gone."

"But humans can become immortal now." Kiari said. "With the Bodily Rejuvenation Depot, humans can return to their youth infinitely."

"Could." Beelzebub gently corrected. "They *could*. But Jason Hiro is gone. He only made one of those. It was on Tarus II."

"So they can't anymore." Kiari said quietly. "Then... our human friends... they're all going to die again?"

"Eventually." Beelzebub said with a nod. "But you never know. Maybe there's still a way those Rejuvenation Depots can return. Or maybe we can make humans like Benjamin Brown flourish. He's immortal because of the robot... stuff... in his body. I don't know. Maybe the humans can reinvent that technology..."

Beelzebub had no idea how anything inside Benjamin Brown's body worked, but the fact that he was made ageless during an era far before the Wordsmith meant it might be possible for the humans to replicate his feat. Unfortunately, solving age weasn't nearly as important to the humans now as surviving past the end of the year.

Their technology was still primitive. Their armies immature. Their numbers pitiful.

Humanity had lost nearly all their champions. Both Wordsmiths were dead. The future seemed pitch-black. Many people assumed they were going to perish before their children made it to adulthood. This state of affairs left them in a tragic mindset.

The two Emperors strode through the city and headed toward Debra's house, somewhere on the east side. The city itself was constructed alongside two rivers that met in an 'X' shape. The rivers flowed into and through one another, splitting Melodia into four distinct quadrants. Bridges crossed the rivers at several points, but in the past the city had naturally settled into split demographics, with humans taking up much of the eastern one. It seemed Melody looked to replicate some of that, though right now the humans outnumbered their demon peers two to one, so they had opted to live in the south and east sides.

As the two walked, a voice suddenly called out to them, as they neared one of the bridges crossing into the east side of Melodia.

"Beelzebub!"

The demon in question turned and glanced at the one who had shouted. He smiled.

"Oh, Orias. Hm? You're still a Baron?"

Orias, Baron of the Stars, strode over and clapped Beelzebub on the back. His status as Emperor didn't seem to affect the warmth in Orias's smile at all.

"*Only* a Baron? That's what you meant, right? Well, some of us aren't living up on Cloud Nine. Don't forget your roots, kid."

In the past, Beelzebub and Orias had spoken on several occasions. They were not best friends or anything, but Orias and Beelzebub's former Master, Agares, could be said to be rather close. They had certainly known each other since the Ancient Era.

Beelzebub scratched his chin and looked away. "Sorry, that wasn't what I meant to imply. Rather, I thought with your connections, you'd had swallowed a couple of those miracle pills and become an Emperor by now."

Orias's smile dimmed. "Those tainted dregs made by that madman, Glinch? I still have standards."

He looked at Kiari. "Oh! And if it isn't the cute little Emperor of Pestilence herself. Helping with the construction efforts?"

Kiari softly shook her head. "I'm... trying to find my husband. Saul. We were together on Tarus II when it... but then I was teleported off-world, and he didn't come with me. I'm at my wit's end..."

Orias's expression turned grave. "That... I'm sorry to hear that, Kiari. So, he's-?"

Kiari's body stiffened. "No, definitely not. We haven't confirmed anything yet. We suspect Solomon might have rescued Saul and taken him to Hope's special area, the Hall of Heroes. He was Saul's uncle, after all."

Orias tried to smile reassuringly, but the effort felt forced. "I see. I'm sure you'll find him there, then."

Beelzebub looked between the two of them, then cleared his throat so he could change the subject. "Orias, heard any interesting gossip from the demon leaders?"

"Nothing as of yet." Orias said, equally glad not to dwell on such a heavy topic. "Last I heard, they were secretly debating whether or not to support humanity."

Beelzebub scoffed. "Support them? Those bastards shoved humanity out of the Core as quickly as they could! What support?!"

"Apparently their tune has changed." Orias said. He looked around, then quickly dragged Beelzebub and Kiari off to the side, further away from the bridge. He lowered his voice. "Have you heard about what happened to the Volgrim?"

Beelzebub's eyes narrowed to slits. "Oh? Something *happened* to them? I would be very interested in good news right about now."

Orias nodded. He quickly summarized the 'current ongoing' situation with a traitor among the Psions. It had already become public knowledge that countless Psions had abruptly perished across the galaxy. This news startled Kiari and shook Beelzebub to his core.

"Just like that?" Beelzebub asked. "The Psions are dead?"

"There are still some scattered survivors." Orias replied. "I spoke to a few different Seers. Some of the Psions were apparently immune to Demila's rampaging. Don't ask me why; I have no idea. But the vast, vast majority have fallen. Even Executor Nufaris."

"Nufaris too?!" Beelzebub exclaimed. His eyes turned feral. "That bastard! I nearly killed him myself, but he managed to evade me with the Second Founder in tow! Now you're telling me he's dead?!"

Orias looked Beelzebub up and down. "So it's true, then. I heard you experienced an Uplifting. But... I don't sense any Cosmic Energy from you. Are you... still a Demon Deity?"

Beelzebub blinked. He crossed his arms and slightly turned away. "I am only a Demon Emperor, once again."

"Ah... I see. I'm sorry to hear that." Orias said. "Well, to answer your question, he's dead for sure. Apparently some incident happened. Mephisto reappeared and wreaked havoc on Volgarius. He killed trillions of Volgrim, then Nufaris sacrificed himself to kill Mephisto. I don't know the details, only what the Seers told me."

"Mephisto... that evil villain." Kiari muttered. "But... isn't this terrible news? The Volgrim were the bulwark against the Plague. Without them, aren't we all in dire straits?"

"You hit the nail on the head." Orias said with a slow nod. "That's why the Demon Deities are thinking of collaborating with the humans."

Kiari's expression darkened. "I think I get it. They don't have Diablo anymore, so they're hoping the humans find a way to counter the Plague. Those shameless leeches! First they bully us, then they beg us for our favor?!"

"The Demon Deities haven't been that bad to the humans." Beelzebub interjected. "They jumped in to help fight off the Kolvaxors during the Battle on Maiura."

"Well, great!" Kiari said sarcastically. "One good deed undoes a hundred bad ones! You know just as well as I do that the Demon Deities have been plotting to wipe the humans out. But now that the Psions are gone, look how quickly they change their tune!"

Beelzebub scratched his chin. Kiari had a point, and he couldn't refute it.

The three of them talked a little while longer. Eventually, Orias bowed his head.

"It has been good catching up with you two, but I have matters to which I must attend."

"You've got stuff going on?" Beelzebub joked. "I thought all you did was dig for gems."

"I have plenty of those for now." Orias replied. "Recently, I have been... contemplating a great many matters. The disappearance of the Wordsmiths, the instability of the universe. Things are becoming *chaotic*, and the threads of karma which bind us grow ever more tenuous. But I feel that soon... in not too distant a future... humanity is bound to experience a shocking upswing in fortune."

"I do hope that makes you feel better." Beelzebub said, sticking his hands in his suit-pants' pockets. "But... it sounds like mumbo-jumbo to me."

"Hehehe... karma and chaos are intertwined." Orias said mysteriously. "Today's atrocities can become tomorrow's guiding lights. As we speak, powerful forces are rallying to move their pieces around the board. You would do well to focus on reacquiring that power which you've lost."

"I'll worry about it when it's important." Beelzebub replied with a shrug. "I've already tasted the power of a Middle Cosmic. When the time is right, I'm sure I'll experience it again."

Orias smiled. "On that subject, we both agree."

The demons bade each other farewell, and Orias strode off.

After he left, Kiari gave Beelzebub a curious look. "So you're really *really* not a Demon Deity anymore?"

Beelzebub smirked. "For now. But don't worry about it. Humanity can still count on me."

* * *

Ten minutes later, they arrived before a humble house built in the center of East Melodia. Lots of people bustled about, and the other residences were crowded together, built densely with three floors each. After looking at the nameplate on the door, Beelzebub spotted two blank rooms that hadn't been inhabited yet, and one with Debra's name on it.

He knocked loudly on the door, but modulated his energy so that it wouldn't come off as aggressive.

Eventually, the door opened, and a blonde woman wearing thick black glasses opened it up to look at him in surprise.

"I... Beelzebub? Kiari?"

"Hi, Debra!" Kiari said with a cheerful wave. "Um, sorry to bother you out of the blue..."

"No, no it's fine." Debra said. "Can I help you with anything?"

She opened the door a little wider and exited onto the front steps. Beelzebub immediately noticed that Debra's eyes looked tired, as if she hadn't experienced good sleep in several days. Considering the man she served, Neil, had been killed by the Kolvaxians, and Hope had fallen right afterward, he imagined she must be experiencing depression and fatigue.

"We, um, we wanted to check on you..." Kiari said hesitantly. "And also ask you for a favor. But if you can't, it's- it's fine..."

"Not many people talk to me these days." Debra said, forcing a weak smile. "I sometimes offer to help Linda with various things, but she often rejects me. She says I should take some time off."

Debra's shoulders sagged. "And then there's the matter of my sister disappearing."

"Your sister?" Beelzebub asked.

"You wouldn't know her. Her name was Annette... and due to some circumstances, she ended up with Hope Hiro. Various things happened. After his death, she apparently vanished from the Hall of Heroes. Nobody knows where she's gone."

"I'm sorry to hear that..." Kiari said quietly. "Though, speaking of the Hall of Heroes, that's what I wanted to talk to you about."

She quickly explained her wishes, and Debra listened silently.

"I'm not exactly 'in' with the current leadership anymore." Debra said. "But I can speak to Henry. If I don't mention you two, I'm sure he'd check in at the Hall of Heroes to see if Saul is there."

"C-could you please?" Kiari asked, her voice jumping an octave. "I would greatly appreciate it."

Debra's eyes softened. "You lost your husband. So did Linda. A lot of spouses have died. This is the least I can do."

After confirming that she would ask Henry the very next day, Debra offered for the two demons to come inside, but they shook their heads.

"We really can't put you out like that." Beelzebub said. "I also have some stuff to deal with."

"Me as well." Kiari said. "I feel guilty that I haven't been using my bugs to help rebuild."

"Well, alright then. How should I contact you once I have news?" Debra asked Kiari.

Kiari gestured in all directions. "If you see one of my big bugs doing something, just go near it and call out my name. I'll know."

"Alright. We'll do it like that then." Debra said. "See you two later..."

She closed the door, then Beelzebub and Kiari walked away.

"I have someone I need to see." Beelzebub said after a few moments of quiet. "Let me know how things go later, Kiari."

Kiari nodded. She looked at Beelzebub with sparkling eyes. "Thank... thank you for being there for me, Beelzebub. You're a good person."

"Hardly." Beelzebub retorted gruffly, but his voice softened a little when he met Kiari's gaze. After a moment, he coughed and looked away. "Take care."

Flames ignited under Beelzebub's feet. He rocketed up into the air and left Kiari behind, taking to Sharmur's skies.

* * *

At the moment Beelzebub became a burning light in the sky, he drew a lot of attention. A pair of ethereal figures immediately noticed him. They turned and stopped, looking up into the sky with surprise.

"Isn't that Beelzebub?" Demon Deity Yardrat asked, his Astral Form having arrived on Sharmur only half an hour before.

"It certainly looks to be him." Demon Deity Kristoff replied. "But... he doesn't have the aura of a Middle Cosmic."

"How is that possible?" Yardrat asked. "One does not simply stop living life as a Demon Deity."

Kristoff frowned. He looked at the ground and rubbed his chin.

"This matter cannot be simple. If Beelzebub is not actually a Demon Deity anymore, than much of our wariness toward humanity is unwarranted. We can still boss them around a bit. Melody alone is not enough to incite our worries."

"Whoa, whoa. Don't be too hasty." Yardrat interjected, raising both his palms. "Beelzebub might only be hiding his aura."

"Is such a thing possible?" Kristoff asked.

Both men paused. They massaged their foreheads, then hemmed and hawed.

"I've never heard of a Demon Deity hiding their aura, but it should be possible..." Yardrat finally said, though his tone was anything but certain. "Why would they not want to broadcast their power?"

Kristoff shrugged. "Beelzebub is rather arrogant. Him hiding his power seems unlikely. It's simply not his style. He probably has reverted back to only being an ordinary Emperor."

"Are you willing to gamble our future on that?!" Yardrat snapped. "If there's even a ten percent chance..."

"Mmm. We should talk to Auger first." Kristoff replied. "We were supposed to come here and inform the human leader, Commander Hurent, of our new plans. But those plans were based on Beelzebub being a threat. If he's not, we definitely, definitely can't rush into any decisions."

After another minute or two of thinking, both Yardrat and Kristoff's forms made a decision. They flew into the air and raced toward Beelzebub at speeds his flaming body could not compare. Naturally, Beelzebub sensed their approach, slowed down in midair, and turned to face the pair of powerful ghostly apparitions.

"Yardrat. Kristoff." Beelzebub said, levitating in the air through flames from his feet. He crossed his arms and assumed his typical domineering stance, not even bothering to use their proper demon titles as a junior peer should. "Need something?"

The two Demon Deities stopped a short distance away. They quickly assessed him from this close distance, but their scans showed that he didn't have a lick of Cosmic Energy inside him.

"Beelzebub... you're an ordinary Demon Emperor now?" Kristoff asked. "I thought you were a Middle Cosmic?"

Beelzebub sneered. "Middle Cosmic? Oh, that. Yes, I temporarily empowered myself to such a level. But it's gone now. I'm back to being an Emperor."

Kristoff was about to sigh in relief, when Beelzebub confidently leered toward him.

"But you're wrong about one thing, Kristoff. You're not dealing with an *ordinary* Demon Emperor."

"What? What does that mean?" Kristoff asked.

Beelzebub didn't explain. He simply retracted his gaze and sneered at the two of them as if they were idiots.

"I nearly had the Second Founder in my grasp." Beelzebub instead said. "Next time, I'll kill her... and anyone else who threatens humanity. You can take that to your graves."

Before the two esteemed Demon Deities could retort, Beelzebub ignited flames hotter than before and raced off across the horizon, leaving them gawking.

"So... he... confirmed it?" Kristoff asked, unsure. "He's not a Cosmic anymore?"

"Imbecile!" Yardrat snapped.

Kristoff turned to look at Yardrat, seeing beads of sweat on his Astral face.

"That was a warning to us!" Yardrat hissed. "I knew it. He's feigning his weakness after all! Why is he pretending to not be a Cosmic anymore? And that bit about not being an 'ordinary' Demon Emperor? It was clearly a naked threat. He must have discovered a method to rise from Mortal to Cosmic and back down at will. That's the best explanation!"

"He seemed like he was only a mortal to me." Kristoff said doubtfully. "I think you're reading between the lines too much."

"Didn't you see the way he treated us so arrogantly?" Yardrat explained. "He didn't put us in his eyes at all! If he really only possessed the power of a mortal, then why would he act so domineeringly in front of genuine Cosmics? It's because he doesn't fear us even a little bit. And that would only be because he hasn't lost his power. He was practically goading us to attack him so we'd get egg on our faces."

"To throw us off our game." Kristoff said, acknowledging Yardrat's words with a nod. "It still seems a little far-fetched, but I see the logic. If we think humanity is weak, we might blunder in and reveal our own weaknesses, allowing him to strike us and deal a grievous blow. It's a good thing you saw through his ploy."

"Let's proceed as we originally planned." Yardrat said, feeling slightly relieved.

The two of them descended from the clouds, heading toward humanity's makeshift new headquarters inside the heart of South Melodia.

Beelzebub was clearly still a threat, but for some unknown reason wanted to play like a harmless kitten hiding in the grass.

They would not let themselves be fooled by his feigned weakness!

And so, unknowingly, these powerful Demon Deities played themselves, with Beelzebub having no idea about the depths of their misunderstanding...

Part 653: Demon's Deal

Far-Future Era. Day 3, AJR. The world of Sharmur.

Linda Adams sat inside a small office by herself in South Melodia. The building she was currently using as a military HQ wasn't anything special, merely a former factory used by humans when they previously lived on Sharmur. As such, it had no special soundproofing, the walls were made of stone and mud, and it felt rather primitive. Using the few miniature replicators they had saved inside the Core, her technicians had fabricated a desk and a chair for her, so she was able to sit in relative comfort.

In the past, Jason Hiro had built several miniature fusion generators with his Wordsmithing, and had even placed several of them inside the Core. However, with Tarus II's destruction, and the demons' forceful eviction of the humans outside of the Core, they had now been moved to Sharmur, along with the few mini-replicators that remained.

The loss of Tarus II and Maiura had set humanity back immeasurably. Before that dreadful day came, the prevailing wisdom was that even if Jason or Hope fought, one of them was likely to survive, so even if the infrastructure was destroyed, at least humanity could rebuild later. But how could anyone predict that both Wordsmiths would die, and both of humanity's bases of power would be snuffed out?

Now, all that remained of their former industrial capabilities were what pittances had been put inside the Core, and whatever Chrona and the Hall of Heroes had tucked away.

But these last two were of no use to Linda. The teleportation devices built inside both Wordsmith's secret dimensional spaces were only made for transporting bipedal bodies and perhaps some small devices on their person. Fabricating and transferring new power sources was a fundamentally impossible task unless someone inside the secret dimensions drastically upgraded and overhauled the teleportation matrices. Fusion generators were inherently volatile, and Fiona wouldn't want to risk a superliminal detonation by transferring a fusion reactor across interdimensional distances.

So, now, humanity in Realspace was suffering from an unexpected crisis.

A stack of papers sat in front of Linda. These were requisition requests, detailing urgent and needed uses for the remaining fabricators. From various parts that could be put together to repair and construct new vehicles, to weapons and armor to help fortify

the military's strength in a time when they had little equipment available, to simply fabricating new T-REX suits, the list of requisitions was daunting.

Linda sighed. She rested her elbow on the desk and chin on her palm, while gazing vacantly at a piece of paper with all sorts of military jargon on it. Humanity's military doctrine was still in its infancy, having lost its ten thousand years of history following the destruction of Earth 100,000 years ago, but Neil had done a decent job building new pipelines for infrastructure, reviving military doctrines from the 1800s that he knew, and integrating those doctrines with newer ones recommended to him by his top generals. Especially Chadwick, who had fought in humanity's Second World War. Linda didn't even know what kind of concept a 'world war' was. She had never lived on Old Earth, so she had no knowledge of humanity's roots.

Linda knew she was unqualified. Unlike Neil, who had been properly trained and led by one of Earth's former Heroes, Napoleon, she had no formal training. She was only an ordinary citizen from one of the worlds enslaved by the demons. She had been promoted to Corporal in a time when resources and personnel were needed quickly, but her talents were better put to use on a battlefield than behind a desk.

Right now, she didn't have much to work with. So many humans had died in the last week that humanity's military had been stretched beyond its limits. The chain of command was broken. Promotions were being haphazardly issued. Unqualified people were being uplifted one after the other, with an aura of disarray being issued one after the other. The Queen Network that had been quite successful in training new initiates had also been lost, and all that remained of it were a few small-scale transceivers in the Core, and one major hub on the world of Pixiv. The Fairies would need to work together to build a new primary hub on Sharmur before training and bootcamps could resume.

Linda massaged her chin. She dropped the paper in her hand onto the desk, slumped back in her chair, and heavily sighed. She felt some of her energy drain away for the tenth time that day.

"Neil... I knew you worked hard... but I never really understood how much we relied on you until now." Linda muttered to herself.

On another day, she might start crying again, but by this point, her tears had already run dry. She was simply too tired to weep. She hadn't been married to him for six months

before fate snatched him away and left her a widow. Now she not only had to lead the military, but raise their child once the baby was born.

It was a lot of responsibility for a single parent.

As she sat in the chair, looking up at the ceiling in a daze, a knock came at the door. Instantly, Linda hardened her expression. She sat up in the chair, took a deep breath, and turned her gaze toward the sound.

"Come in." Linda said.

The door opened. A woman with light grey hair in a ponytail carefully stepped into the office.

"Miss Adams?"

Linda faintly smiled, the expression a mixture of being forced because she wasn't really in the mood to smile, but also a little genuine because she had no hard feelings toward the person who entered.

"Corporal Sariah. Is something the matter?"

Sariah, one of the Felorians, now wore a green pressed suit with a beret instead of her somewhat skimpy tribalwear. This was not strictly necessary, but after the humans lost so many people over the last several days, she voluntarily chose to enter humanity's proper military, giving up some of her cultural identity to better fit into an increasingly thinned-out army structure.

"There are two Demon Deities here to see you." Sariah said, looking neither scared nor flustered. "It's Kristoff and Yardrat."

Linda hesitated for a moment. She really wasn't in the mood for a high-stakes discussion with a pair of powerful demons, but she was the only person qualified to do so, which meant she really had no choice. She exhaled quietly, then nodded.

"Okay. Send them in."

Sariah nodded. She stepped back out, and a moment later, ushered the two 'guests' inside. Yardrat and Kristoff entered, their bodies faintly transparent due to being in their Astral bodies.

After the door closed, Yardrat opened his mouth to speak, only to pause and look behind Linda. She turned and nearly jumped out of her skin when she realized someone

was standing right behind her, having appeared without her noticing.

"Mother of-! You scared the shit out of me, Melody!"

Demon Deity Melody crossed her arms apologetically. "Sorry. I sensed these two had come. I wanted to make sure I was present for whatever they were planning to say."

Unspoken, Melody implied she was here to protect Linda just in case these two Demon Deities had any ill intentions. Linda calmed down, but she had unfortunately already acted startled, so any form of imposing presence on her part had been lost.

She returned her gaze to Yardrat, feeling slightly glum. If it had been Neil, he would have remained unruffled by Melody's appearance. Now she felt as if any chance of appearing strong before these two unwanted guests was in the past. They would be the ones to lead the discussion.

"Commander Adams." Yardrat said. "Auger sent us here to have a talk with you. Melody is already aware of the general... concept."

"I am." Melody said, her tone bland. She maintained her crossed arms while giving the other two Deities a look that implied they should know their boundaries. While on Sharmur, their astral bodies could project the strength of a Demon Emperor, but there were limitations, and they were a bit weaker than flesh and blood Emperors. They would completely lose if Melody decided to disperse their astral bodies forcefully.

"We've come to make a proposal." Yardrat continued. "We know we haven't done our best to assist humanity. After the losses of both your home planets, we've decided to try and help you out. With the Plague becoming more dangerous every day, we need to work together in times like these."

Linda slowly nodded, but Melody didn't.

"Not going to mention how you kicked the humans out of the Core the day they lost everything?" Melody asked. "That's convenient."

Yardrat smiled apologetically. "We made a rash decision in the heat of the moment, but no real harm was done. We didn't attack any humans, and we didn't hurt anyone. We simply... took back that which was ours."

"Are you here to give us control of the Core once again?" Linda asked.

"Well... no." Yardrat said carefully. "The Core is part of the Labyrinth, and the Labyrinth belongs to demonkind. But we are here to assist humanity in rebuilding itself.

We would like to send demons and monsters to Sharmur who are specialists in construction. They can help you rebuild quickly, and give you a new center of operations. We're also going to make the same offer to the humans on Pixiv."

Linda frowned. "This feels like it's coming out of thin air."

"It isn't." Yardrat said. "I know the demons and humans have had our differences. Emperor Ose committed a terrible sin by attacking Tarus II during Operation Stormbringer. But neither Kristoff nor I were involved in that. That was the fault of the First Hell. And these days.. the First Hell isn't worth talking about. Its strongest member is... Bael? And he's lost all his powers. Now, Deity Auger wishes to make up for the sins of the past."

Kristoff nodded. "That's why we came to help Maiura when the Plague attacked."

Naturally, Linda remembered when they intervened. The Demon Deities made a big difference in the battle and saved many lives, even if they weren't able to offer salvation to all of humanity's soldiers.

"So that's it then? You want to help us rebuild? Put the past behind us?" Linda asked. "That is an awfully good deal for us."

"We have plenty of free hands idling around." Kristoff explained. "Trillions and trillions of demons. You lack manpower more than anything."

"Ahem!" Melody loudly cleared her throat and shot a death glare at the other two Deities. "Aren't you two *forgetting* something?"

Yardrat shook his head. "Our offer today has nothing to do with that."

"Why not?" Melody asked, before turning her head to look at Linda. "I should have known he wouldn't volunteer this information. He wanted to speak to you before you found out."

Linda met Melody's gaze. "What are you talking about?"

"There's been a change in the galactic status quo. Multiple changes." Melody explained.

She quickly launched into an explanation of the events regarding the fall of the Psions, as well as the rise of the Dolgrimites. Linda listened attentively, but her expression changed when the Dolgrimites were brought up.

"They can defeat the Plague?! Melody, why didn't you mention this to me sooner?"

"The battle between the Dolgrimites and Kolvaxians only happened yesterday." Melody explained, though her tone was apologetic. "Auger convened the Deities less than an hour ago to inform us all. He *didn't* invite me, but I found out anyway because I'm nobody's fool. Now the demons are debating whether or not to align themselves with the Dolgrimites."

Melody shifted her eyes to Yardrat and sneered. "You really think you're slick. You wanted to quickly make a deal with the humans before they knew the full picture."

"It's not like that at all!" Yardrat replied, raising his palms in protest. "We were already going to make this offer. Our consciences have been heavy-"

"Cut the crap." Melody retorted. "If you don't, I'll personally kick you off Sharmur. Don't blame me for getting pissy!"

Yardrat inwardly groaned. He had hoped this discussion wouldn't involve Melody, but she shoved her way into Linda's office and ruined his plans. Now he had to change the script on the fly. He was a fairly intelligent demon, but he was no Ose, nor Satan, nor one of their other high-level strategists.

"...Alright. I'll be blunt then." Yardrat said after a few moments of silence. "I don't trust the Dolgrimites. They might act like they are our saviors, but this 'Dolgris' worries me. We don't know who their 'god' is, but we suspect he isn't a fantasy conjured out of thin air. The Dolgrimites were able to defeat Kolvaxors with the power of Middle Cosmics. How they did this is beyond me. They are clearly mortal beings, yet they can fight Cosmics. That makes them dangerous."

Yardrat continued. "If demonkind allies with the Dolgrimites, we will likely defeat the Plague, given time. But after that, what happens? We cannot trust them. We've already spent 100,000 years under the Volgrim Empire's thumb. We'll escape one master only to fall back under them, with a new figurehead at the top."

"You forgot to mention the most important part." Melody interjected. "You can't *control* the Dolgrimites. But a weak humanity? A species confined to only two worlds, on its last legs? Humans would make for a better ally because you hope to slowly subvert their leadership positions while also praying they come up with their own countermeasure for the Plague."

"Melody, please-" Kristoff started to say.

"Shut up!" Melody snapped. "I see right through your intentions! You're not looking for an ally, you're looking for slaves! You plan to slowly turn humanity back into cattle so that you can return to consuming their souls! Especially with the Belial Booster gone, you're right back to the old status quo!"

"We have Glinch's pills now." Yardrat said, his expression dark. "We don't need human souls to uplift lower demons."

"Those pills have run out, their supply is finite, and nobody knows how long it will take for Glinch to make more." Melody retorted. "Who are you trying to fool?"

Yardrat started to feel exasperated. He turned his attention back to Linda. "Commander Adams, think carefully. The First Hell was your enemy, but what have the other Hells ever done to you in the last six years? We have only helped you, time and time again. The knee-jerk reaction in the Core might have been distasteful, but all we did was retake our proper territory. Now we're offering to help you rebuild. Aren't you at least interested in this offer?"

Melody fell silent. She had already offered new information and ensured Linda was not in the dark regarding their intentions. Now, it was up to humanity's newest leader to take the initiative.

Linda locked her fingers together and folded her hands on the desk. She looked up at Yardrat and Kristoff, who remained standing. Several thoughts ran through her head, but she remained silent for a time as she pondered their words.

"Your intentions are not that noble, but I don't disagree with some of the things you've mentioned." Linda said. "Humanity needs to rebuild its infrastructure. This will take precious time we cannot afford. I feel that allowing in demons from your factions here will be as if we have invited foxes into the hen-house."

Linda rubbed her tongue along her teeth while she thought again for a moment.

"What do you want in return for demonkind's assistance?"

Yardrat shook his head. "Nothing. We have plenty of lower demons to spare. They will help you rebuild, then they will leave."

"Don't speak nonsense." Linda countered. "There's no such thing as a free meal. I'm not about to owe demonkind a huge favor."

"Humanity cannot offer us anything of value at the moment." Yardrat said. "What we value is your future potential. We are hoping you might come up with a way to counter the Plague. If you do, then that will mean we won't be reliant on the Dolgrimites. So, if you want to make this a transaction... then all I can ask is that you agree to work hard on developing a counter to the Plague."

Several seconds passed.

Linda seemed to resolve something in her mind. Then she slowly nodded.

"Alright. I will accept your aid in humanity's name. But there are going to be a few conditions. Your demons will be under the supervision of the Legion. If Henry or any of the other Legionnaires find anything amiss, they will cut down the demons responsible. Additionally, no demons above the rank of Lord will be allowed to assist."

Yardrat frowned slightly, but he ended up nodding. "Acceptable. Though it is strange you're limiting the aid you can receive."

Linda didn't seem to hear his words. "Melody will be in charge of vetting any demons you dispatch to us. Melody, you can put Beelzebub or Kiari on this task if you find it too troublesome."

"Don't worry. I'll handle it." Melody said.

The other two Deities looked at each other and nodded. They returned their gazes to Linda.

"Well, with that resolved, we'll be on our way then. Thank you for giving us a few minutes of your time, Miss Adams."

Linda stood up from her chair. "Yardrat. Kristoff. Let's hope this is the beginning of a fruitful relationship between our species."

The two Deities smiled. After a few moments, their Astral Bodies faded away, disappearing into the dust of the cosmos.

With their auras gone, Linda's shoulder sagged a little. She sat back in her chair and looked up at Melody.

"Thank you for coming. If you hadn't been here, they might have deceived me."

"The result would have been about the same." Melody said softly. She lowered her arms to her sides and hooked her thumbs into her shorts' pockets. "I don't think we can

trust them."

"Of course we can't." Linda said. "But... I'm tired, Melody. *I'm tired*. There's so much work to do. So many people broken, destitute, lacking all hope in a better future. We have no Wordsmiths. We only have each other, and humanity has already had its numbers split into pieces. We have people living on the Cube, on Pixiv, on Sharmur, in the Hall of Heroes, and in Chrona. We're divided. Everyone has a different opinion on what we should do next. And personally? I have no confidence my way is the right way. I'm just floundering about, praying my actions won't cause even greater harm to humanity."

Melody pursed her lips. "'Perfect' is the enemy of 'good enough.' You're right in that we need manpower to rebuild quickly. Even if these new demons have ill intentions, we'll be keeping an eye on them. You might not know this, but as a Cosmic, my senses are infinitely sharper than yours."

Seeing the confusion on Linda's face, Melody decided to explain. "I can project my Cosmic Sense over a massive area of the planet. I can sense every individual life-form, every Sentient, what they're doing, what they're saying; I can see everything but the thoughts in their heads. The same is true of the other Demon Deities, but not of mortals like Beelzebub, Kiari, or yourself."

She smiled. "So, don't worry too much. I'll keep an eye on these sneaky cunts."

Linda chuckled. "Thanks, Melody. I need all the help I can get."

With a nod, Melody vanished from sight, transporting out of the room stealthily back into the upper atmosphere.

Linda remained sitting for a bit. The smile on her face faded away.

The Wordsmiths dead. Humanity in pieces. Demons boldly entering our territory. Dolgrimites countering the Plague...

She laid back in her chair and looked up at the ceiling helplessly.

What would Neil do if he were here?

Part 654: Torn Dimension

Far-Future Era. Day 3, AJR. The world of Sharmur.

The midday sun slowly waned across the sky above Melodia. It dropped to the edge of the horizon, and a warm redness tinged the upper atmosphere. The sounds of hammering could be heard across the entire city as humans, monsters, and demons worked to repair and rebuild hundreds of structures. Like a swarm of ants, their numbers seemed incalculable from above. They were visible on every street, rooftop, porch, and other protrusion as far as the eye could see.

It was against this backdrop that a particularly eye-catching sight became visible far above them. Many people paused their work to wipe the sweat off their foreheads. They looked up to see a flaming figure slowly moving from east to west. With no airplanes or rockets or other technology taking to the sky, usually the only flying objects they would see were birds, bugs, harpies, fairies, the occasional drone delivering supplies, and a few very specific demons.

Beelzebub was one of those demons.

His figure cut through the air without trying to conceal himself. He drew plenty of attention, but he had become such a common sight that most people forgot about him within a few minutes of observing his movements.

Beelzebub reached the border of the city, where a massive mountain range stood to the west. This range extended not only along the west, but it also curved around and cut across the north as well. Two massive waterfalls could be seen, one that poured from the western side, and one from the north. The waters of each flowed together and formed the plus-shaped aquatic junction that Melodia had long ago been built around.

Access to fresh water was a necessity for humans. Demons also preferred it because it made certain things, such as bathing, more convenient. Technology was rather primitive on Sharmur, and the former humans and demons who had once lived on this world had no real access to the same plumbing utilities they had on old Earth.

Beelzebub's flight wasn't particularly fast. He had been busy for the last couple of days, and a lot was weighing on his mind. His speed decreased even further as he neared the

western cliffside, found a rock outcropping that stuck tens of feet out above the valley below, and came to a stop atop that outcropping.

Beelzebub turned and stared out at the waning sun to the east. Far away, he could barely make out the ocean on the horizon. A vast forest stood between Melodia and that ocean, but with his keen devil vision, he could make out countless details mortals could not.

A long while passed. He sat down in a cross-legged position, a complicated expression playing upon his face.

Nobody in the galaxy knew who Beelzebub truly was. His connections, few though they were, had slowly been snuffed out one after the other over the last few years.

Ose might have been the only woman he loved, but she was dead.

Jason Hiro was a pain in his ass, but Beelzebub respected him. He was dead too.

Agares was gone.

So many... were gone.

Beelzebub rested his palms on his knees. His eyes turned fuzzy as he thought back on his life.

He pondered what sort of man he had become.

Was he satisfied with the way things were going?

Was he content with the state of the galaxy?

No.

For some reason, he felt a heavy burden had slowly begun to accumulate atop his shoulders. Many demons believed he was a Demon Deity now, but he wasn't. If the villains among his species took action, he could not protect humanity.

Heh.

'Protect humanity.'

Those words were nothing to his younger self but an absurdity. Why would he give a damn about these pathetic, weak, useless humans? He had no friends among them!

...Or did he?

There was one man. Kiari's husband, Saul.

He was... a good human.

But Beelzebub sensed, in his heart, the ugly truth. Saul was dead.

Just like Agares, Ose, and Jason. He had not survived the detonation of Tarus II. He had left his wife a widow, and Beelzebub had lost another friend.

The feeling was... indescribable.

Beelzebub lowered his eyes. He looked at the waterfall that pounded into the forest below, forcibly carving out a river that wound its way through the trees.

In many ways, this river was like the river of time. Time could make the impossible, possible. Even the deepest roots could be slowly softened and then ripped out, let alone when excessive force was applied.

"I am weak." Beelzebub said to nobody in particular. "Too weak. I have done nothing but fail my entire life."

A voice spoke out from behind Beelzebub. "Admitting one's weakness is a form of strength."

Beelzebub frowned. He had come here for solitude, yet this voice had slightly startled him.

He turned his head to see a human slowly walking toward him from behind. He couldn't sense the human's aura at all.

"And you are?" Beelzebub asked.

In the back of his head, Beelzebub suspected this strangely stealthy human wasn't a human at all. He might actually be Belial in disguise, here to prank the Overlord of Fission. This didn't entirely make sense, since Beelzebub had just spoken to her, but women could be strange sometimes.

"It's unfortunate that this is the first time we've met." The man said, his expression becoming an amiable smile. He sauntered over and extended his hand. "Siddhartha Gautama. But you may call me 'Buddha.'"

Beelzebub raised an eyebrow, but he still met Buddha's palm with a firm yet not too overbearing handshake.

"Beelzebub." He said, introducing myself. "Do you need something, *Buddha*? I'm trying to enjoy the sunset."

"Oh? Are you?" Budda asked, taking a step back. He walked over to the edge of the mountain, let his legs hang off the side of the cliff, and sat down without any fear of the thousand-meter fall. "It seemed to me that you were moping around, lamenting your life's failures. Perhaps I misheard."

Beelzebub snorted. He returned his attention back to the sunset and said nothing else.

Several minutes passed.

Beelzebub felt Buddha's continual gaze on his back. Finally, he turned around and glared at the man. "Do you have a problem?"

"Hm? A problem?" Buddha asked innocently. "I am simply enjoying the sunset, same as you."

"Yeah. *Ha-ha*. Very funny." Beelzebub spat.

"Sharmur is a beautiful world." Buddha said, looking off into the distance wistfully. He didn't seem to notice Beelzebub's annoyance. "The setting of the sun brings nightfall, and night leads into the new day, with new opportunities. A lot can change in a single day. I'm sure you know this all too well."

Beelzebub's eyes flickered. He remembered the fall of Tarus II, and the complete upheaval of the status quo that happened only a few days before.

"Yes." Beelzebub admitted, lowering his eyes. "A lot can change."

"I sense great loneliness from you, Beelzebub." Buddha said. "You feel as though you were once a figure destined for greatness. But now, despite having attained the power you once thought invincible in the universe, you have encountered a sky above the sky. The power of a Demon Emperor has turned out not to be much at all compared to that of a Cosmic."

Beelzebub softly sighed.

"I owe Jason Hiro a debt. I did so many awful things to him... I even killed his daughter. But he spared my life. In the end, I wasn't able to stop that catastrophe, and I wasn't even able to gut the *bitch* who caused it."

"You couldn't pay Jason back." Buddha said.

"Right." Beelzebub muttered. "Couldn't... pay him back."

A minute of silence passed.

"Then what comes next?" Buddha eventually asked. "What are your plans?"

Beelzebub looked off into the distance. "I haven't a clue. Right now I'm only going through the motions."

Buddha eyed his profile from the side. "You have no goals right now. No purpose."

Beelzebub really wasn't sure why he was even having a conversation with this random human. Other than his odd lack of aura and somewhat otherworldly way of talking, Buddha didn't seem particularly special.

Perhaps Beelzebub was... simply bored at the moment. A little conversation helped to pass the time.

"I'm a demon. I've reached the peak of mortal demonic power. The only place left for me to go is up... to the level of Cosmic. But being a Cosmic isn't all sunshine and roses."

"Becoming a Cosmic is a heavy burden." Buddha agreed, nodding his head with a sagely slowness. "There are countless mortals and their machinations in our universe. But the number of Cosmics is a far, far smaller fraction. Cosmics are intended only to battle against other Cosmics. Interfering in the affairs of mortals is heavily punished by Akasha."

With a jolt, Beelzebub lifted his head. He looked at Beelzebub in surprise. "You know of Akasha?! Who are you?"

"I have friends in many places." Buddha said with a smile. "One of those friends is the Creator. He has told me about you on a few occasions. Unfortunately, you are no longer a Candidate, but you still have extreme potential. He sent me here to advise you."

Beelzebub's heart throbbed in his chest. He quickly stood up and gave Buddha a long, hard look.

"You're not a human." Beelzebub stated.

"Oh, I assure you, I am. You can kill the likes of me with a flick of your finger." Buddha replied. "Though, I would prefer if you didn't. Reincarnating is such a hassle."

Another bolt of electricity shot through Beelzebub's veins. He couldn't tell if the comment about reincarnation was a deception or a joke. How could it be true?!

"If you're here to 'advise' me, then what are you advising me about?" Beelzebub asked, his tone somewhat interrogative.

The human pressed his palms together thoughtfully. "'We' do not wish to see you lost and uncertain. I was sent here to give you a bit of direction."

He continued. "In recent days, you have seen fit to *slightly* explore the greater possibilities of your demonic powers. You made an important discovery as a result of your talks with a certain Psion. Isn't that the case?"

Beelzebub blinked. "Executor Sartran. Yeah. He opened my eyes... made me realize that... I wield more than just the power of fire. I control lightning as well. Energy."

"And what have you done with that knowledge? Have you explored it further?" Buddha asked.

Beelzebub grimaced. "Not really."

"You have seized Sartran's soul. He is your puppet now. I would advise you to stop wasting this opportunity and speak to him as soon as possible." Buddha advised. "You have barely tapped into a fundamental Truth, but your absolute lack of curiosity is rather... infuriating. Even an average human would desire to explore their powers more than you have. You're the same as Jason Hiro in his early days, but you should be emulating his more recent accomplishments."

Beelzebub nodded. He looked down thoughtfully. "It seems like you're saying that becoming a Cosmic isn't all that important? Instead, I should become a more capable Peak Mortal?"

"You are a Demon Overlord." Buddha said, startling Beelzebub once again. "The other demons do not even realize such a level exists. They still believe Emperor is the highest strength your species can reach. Instead, Emperor is the limit of what soul manipulation can attain. Crossing the gap from Emperor to Cosmic is so difficult because it ignores the existence of the level in between! That is why demons were never able to break through for so many millennia."

"How the hell do you know about Demon Overlords?!" Beelzebub asked.

Buddha didn't reply. Instead, he faintly smirked, cocked his head, and gave Beelzebub a knowing look.

"...Right." Beelzebub said a few moments later. "The Creator."

"The Creator." Buddha affirmed. "But though the demons have not realized the rank of Overlord exists, that does not mean none have achieved it. Satan did, as well as Belial,

Valac, and most recently, Crow. There is one other who holds the rank of Overlord. Can you guess who it is?"

Beelzebub fell silent for a time. He thought carefully.

"Auger, before his ascension to Middle Cosmic?"

"No." Buddha replied. "*Gorn*."

"What? Emperor Gorn is actually an Overlord??" Beelzebub asked, bewildered.

"That is right. Gorn has swallowed more souls that you can imagine. While the limit of soul manipulation is technically Emperor, that is only the soft limit. In theory, if one can devours tens or even hundreds of millions of souls, it is possible to push beyond that limit... but to become a Cosmic is utterly impossible. This is the limit set down by Akasha himself."

Buddha waved his hand. "Let us move on to other matters. Slaughtering innocents is an atrocity that goes against the will of the cosmos, but mastering one's own power is something worth rejoicing over. I believe I've given you enough basic guidance. Advanced knowledge cannot come from me, as I am no adept in the mastery of elements."

Buddha stood up. He stuck his hands in his pockets. "Now, if you wish to train in the martial way, that is something I can help you with."

"What, like hand-to-hand combat?" Beelzebub scoffed. "That's beneath me. Pass."

Buddha narrowed his eyes. "From your tone of voice, it seems you think physical combat is a lower form of fighting than flinging around fireballs and lightning. Did you not hear a word I said earlier? Training your current body to its maximum potential will make you far more fearsome than simply artificially inflating your strength by stepping into the Cosmic ranks. A fully actualized mortal, especially a Peak Mortal, is absolutely capable of defeating a Bottom Cosmic. The difference becomes even more dramatic as your power increases!"

"I can already beat anyone." Beelzebub bragged. "I don't need all this 'special training.' Mastering my magic is more than good enough for my goals."

"HAH!" Buddha laughed. "The young are truly foolish! Alright. I am but a mere human. If you think you are so formidable... what say we have a little match?"

By now, Beelzebub was sneering in his heart. "A match? Are you serious? You've been a funny man up until now, but I didn't take you for a clown. How do you intend to fight

me? I might accidentally kill you when I blink my eyes!"

"If I die, then so be it." Buddha replied, unmoved by Beelzebub's threats. "I only intend to prove to you that you are far less formidable than you could be. How about this? We will spar for... ten minutes! If you can throw me onto my back or send me flying, I will never bother you again. But if you fail to do so, then you will meet me every day for the next six months atop this mountain. I will train you until you beg for death, and you will learn to love my methods!"

Beelzebub's pride swelled with irritation. "Ten minutes? This won't even take me ten seconds! If you want to turn your body into ground meat, then I'll humor you! When do we start?"

Buddha leaned backward and assumed a defensive pose.

"Right now."

Far-Future Era. Day 3, AJR. Tarus II voidspace.

Crumbling ruins of a destroyed planet radiated outward across the Tarus system. Not only had the Trifrancium detonation obliterated the sole life-bearing planet in the system, it had also destroyed its moon. Debris from the detonation slowly flew outward in all directions. Someday, perhaps within a year, or hundreds of years, that debris would collide with the other worlds in the system and cause cataclysms everywhere. But that day would not come for a long time.

All that transpired within the Tarus system fell within the eyes of one Cosmic entity. She looked upon the lives lost with faint sadness. As a spirit artifact created by the ancient Archangel, Camael, the Phoenix held a certain love for life and was not made to wreak havoc and destruction upon the cosmos. She could be treated as a weapon, but she was never intended to be one.

"How tragic." The Phoenix said, for perhaps the hundredth time.

Inside the Cube, countless life-bearing micro-worlds spun in place, bunches of them grouped together and illuminated by false stars in order to form day and night cycles. The Phoenix's ample energy reserves allowed her to rapidly construct and improve on stellar phenomena, so she was extremely adept at forming worlds and stars for living beings.

A Sentry Star flew over to the Phoenix. Its massive size was dwarfed even further by her supermassive body, which by now had grown to become bigger than the Earth's moon.

[TASK COMPLETED. SECTOR 14 RUNNING AT 87.5% OPTIMUM EFFICIENCY.]

The Phoenix turned her attention to her assistant.

[That's all?]

[OPTIMAL LIFE-BEARING EFFICIENCY ACHIEVED. EMOTIONAL POSITIVITY INDEX OF INHABITANTS IN SECTOR 14 RATED AT SIX POINT SEVEN THREE THREE. FURTHER OPTIMIZATIONS NOT REQUIRED.]

The phoenix's face scrunched together into a frown. [Only 6.733 out of 10? We can do better than that. Is something not to their liking?]

[COMPLAINTS REGISTERED: LIVING SPACE INADEQUATE. LACK OF SUPERIOR-QUALITY BEDDING. LACK OF ADJUSTABLE LIGHTING. ALL COMPLAINTS DESIGNATED MINOR, NOT WORTH FOLLOWING UP.]

[The humans have suffered a terrible trauma.] The Phoenix said gently. [We should try to make their stay here more comfortable. I'm already working to add more connection matrices between each bubble world. You should improve their living conditions until the happiness index achieves at least an eight out of ten.]

[FURTHER OPTIMIZATIONS UNNECESSARY. ADDITIONAL IMPROVEMENTS WILL LEAD TO DIMINISHING RETURNS. RECOMMEND REFOCUSING ON MORE IMPORTANT CONCERNS.]

[Number 14, don't you get smart with me.] The Phoenix said, in a voice tone a mother might use to admonish her child. [You will do as I say. Continue improving the humans' living conditions.]

The Sentry Star seemed to shudder.

[COMMAND NOTED.]

Without another word, it instantly spun around, then launched off into the distance from a standstill, moving far faster than its size would imply was possible.

The Phoenix sighed again. [They've all become so naughty and belligerent while I was asleep. It seems I'm going to have to adjust their programming lat- HMM?! Who's there?]

The Phoenix suddenly turned her head. She looked to the side, and there she saw something shocking. A tiny crack between dimensions flickered for an instant, and a faint, malevolent aura seeped through. It vanished, but she remained fully alert.

[Who dares intrude upon this noble one's domain?!] The Phoenix shouted.

A moment later, space flickered again. Then again.

Her heart turned cold. That spatial flicker finally stabilized, leaving only a tiny pinprick of evil aura to spill into the Cube's interior. It wasn't anything that would harm the humans, but its owner...

[You! To think you were still alive!] The Phoenix roared.

[Heh heh heh... Phoenix... so it is you. I thought I sensed your aura again.] A male voice said, his tone deep and sinister as the bottom of an ocean. [Have you missed me?]

The Phoenix turned her entire body to face the spatial crack. Her eyes narrowed to slits.

[The fact you haven't come here in person... are you afraid this ancient one will seal you back up?]

[You've regained some of your power.] The male voice said. [But it is not worth mentioning compared to this god. I have spent three eons stabilizing my position in the galaxy. My power grows by the cycle. Soon, I will be capable of contesting the position of Ruler.]

The Phoenix's eyes flickered. [This aura... Apex Cosmic? But if you're so strong, then why are you afraid of me?]

[I'm not.] The male said. [I just felt... nostalgic. All those years you tortured this god... I want you to know I'm still alive. I want you to know the fear of my existence. Now, you will not be able to do your work uplifting that pitiful species of 'humans' while knowing I have the absolute advantage. My followers are powerful enough to blot out the stars. I have spared no expense in raising them.]

He chuckled menacingly. [I've practically finished the race, while you have yet to begin. This battle is already decided. Once I get my hands on you, I'll be repaying you for all those eons of torture!]

The Phoenix's flames ignited with wrath. Her burning gaze seemed to bore through the hole between dimensions.

[This noble one may not be your match now, but are you truly so certain I will lose?! Evilspawn. This noble one has known of your existence since I returned. You did not surprise this noble one. You do not intimidate this noble one. You are but a fragment of a long-dead ancient power. If you are an 'Apex Cosmic' then you are a bottom feeder among their lofty ranks.]

[Well spoken, tormentor.] The male said, seeming to grin with his words. [Spit all the fire you want. It no longer matters. This god has already won. Heh heh heh...]

With a wave of her wing, the Phoenix forcibly smashed the spatial storm, sending a pulse of feedback along the dimensional rift and hopefully injuring her ancient adversary.

The Phoenix's eyes momentarily clouded. She fell into thought for thirty short minutes.

[Number 1. Adjust the Cube's heading.] She said, transmitting her thoughts to one of the Sentry Stars. [Take us to the Sharmur system.]

[ORDERS RECEIVED.] Sentry Star Number 1 replied.

Part 655: Buddhabub's Battle

Far-Future Era. Day 3, AJR. Sharmur, in the mountains west of Melodia.

Beelzebub and Buddha stood next to the edge of a cliff, perhaps twenty feet separating them from a thousand-foot plunge to the bottom of the ravine. However, there was still the entire flat side of the mountain-top in the other direction up to the tree-line, so their designated battle arena had plenty of room to maneuver.

Buddha slapped his chest. The T-REX hidden beneath his black long-sleeved shirt sprang to life and started coating his body with advanced nanite armor. This was the most advanced T-REX Phoebe had made before her death, and the only one she would ever make again. Beelzebub didn't make a move, but instead watched as the nanites covered the man's body.

"Those nanites won't save you if I get serious." Beelzebub said calmly. "Do you have the slightest idea how powerful I am?"

Buddha smiled as the nanites climbed up his head and formed a faceless helmet, swallowing his mouth, eyes, and nose. "Admittedly, if you were to attack me with lethal force, I would die. But remember, all you have to do is knock me to the ground. That is your one goal. Do not hold back in achieving this purpose."

Beelzebub snorted. He couldn't possibly take this fight seriously. A mere mortal human had no chance of beating him in a serious fight.

But a spar? It might be a little fun. At least it would be fun to show this 'Buddha' how big the difference was between himself and the strongest demon in the mortal realm.

Without warning, Beelzebub detonated a flame behind himself and launched forward, sweeping a palm at Buddha's chest. With one ruthless strike, he intended to slam the human into the ground and teach him the difference between the sky and the mud!

Buddha sidestepped. His hand swept upward, and he simultaneously swatted Beelzebub's arm aside while also jumping backward with his left leg and kicking Beelzebub's ribs with his right.

Beelzebub let out a strange cry of surprise before finding his entire momentum thrown off. Buddha kicked him to the side with enough force to launch him off the edge of the

cliff. Beelzebub let out a muffled yelp before hurtling to the bottom of the ravine below. A second later, he ignited flames beneath his feet, reversed his momentum, and flew back up to the top of the cliff.

When he landed, his cool and cocky smile was gone. He felt a little humiliated by the fact that his attack was seen through and neutralized in so decisive a fashion.

And by a mere human at that!

"Apologies." Buddha said smilingly beneath his helmet. "I didn't realize your footwork was so shoddy."

"You!" Beelzebub snapped.

He launched himself at Buddha again in a fit of rage. He still held back his power, not wanting to accidentally kill the human, but right when he drew within range, he detonated a shockwave of flame around his body, aiming to pummel Buddha into the ground without giving him a chance to grab and retaliate.

The shockwave struck Buddha, but he had already firmly planted his feet at just the right angle. When the shockwave slammed into him, it merely pressed his armored boots several inches into the dirt while also clearing away all the random plants and vegetation in the area within thirty meters.

Beelzebub's eyes flashed with shock, but never did he expect that Buddha would then use the shockwave's pressure to coil power into his knees before jumping directly at Beelzebub.

"???" Beelzebub let out another strangled cry of surprise as the lowly human pounced at him with a fist raised.

Thwack!

Buddha punched Beelzebub in the side of his head with the full strength of the T-REX, shattering the side of Beelzebub's jaw, breaking off multiple teeth, and punting him down into the dirt. Beelzebub struck the ground and dragged along it for over twenty feet, digging a shallow ditch with the side of his face. Naturally, he had received far worse blows hundreds of times, so his face regenerated almost immediately, but it was still a humiliating loss!

"Urgh! You spawn of a broodmother!" Beelzebub groaned as he jumped back up to his feet and spit bloody teeth all over the dirt. "You're really starting to piss me off!"

Buddha had already landed on his feet. He took a three-legged stance, with his left palm pressing against the ground and his right hand balled into a fist.

"Hoho..." Buddha chuckled mirthlessly. "Already, thirty seconds have passed, yet the great Beelzebub has failed to knock this lowly mortal human into the dirt. What a stain on your great name this must be, eh?"

"Shut up!!" Beelzebub roared. He decided to punch several fireballs at the human, setting them to low heat and power but with high concussive force. Even if he was pissed, he really didn't want to kill the human by accident, so he continued to focus on tactics that would knock him down and wear him out.

Those fireballs flew at Buddha with frightening speed, but the ancient Reincarnator didn't seem perturbed. He darted to the right, then to the left, then to the right again while explosions detonated behind him, to his side, and even in the dirt in front of him. Some of those explosions knocked him around a little, but not once did they throw him further than a foot or two. Beelzebub felt secretly shocked at how ineffective these fireballs were. How the hell was Buddha still standing?

Unbeknownst to Beelzebub, Buddha wasn't only dodging from side to side. He also slowly moved forward, carefully closing the gap between himself and his much more powerful adversary. At the right moment, when he noticed a gap between two of Beelzebub's fireballs, he lunged forward, stomping against the ground as he made a mad dash directly at Beelzebub's chest!

Beelzebub didn't even have time to react. Buddha tackled him to the ground and drove the wind out of Beelzebub's lungs before quickly jumping backward and making distance. Beelzebub recovered almost instantly, but he was even more pissed than before.

"Lucifer's tits! You know I'm taking it easy on you, right?!" Beelzebub snapped. "If I wanted you dead, you'd be dead a thousand times! Don't mistake my mercy for weakness!"

"I never said I did." Buddha said calmly. "You are correct. If you seriously wanted me dead, I would be dead. Thank you for adhering to the spirit of the match."

Beelzebub frowned. Buddha's 'apology' seemed to slap him across his face, making him feel a little ashamed. Wasn't it beneath him to brag about his strength to a mere human?!

His mind moved quickly. He gazed at Buddha, who had assumed a defensive stance once again.

If this takes me any longer, I'm going to eternally be unable to look myself in the mirror. How do I knock him flat on his ass in the shortest time possible?

An instant later, Beelzebub snapped his palm forward. A bolt of lightning fired directly at Buddha, but the man tossed a rock in front of himself while dodging to the right. That rock redirected the lightning just enough that it arced off to the side and slammed into the forest behind himself, lightning a fire. Buddha, however, was unharmed.

"You saw through my lightning?!" Beelzebub exclaimed in bewilderment.

"No. But your movements are sloppy, basic, and predictable." Buddha said, never taking his eyes off his opponent. "You have no combat sense. You haven't even yet determined what our spar is all about. You are as arrogant as ever, thinking in the back of your mind that you should win purely based on the strength of your magic. You're so used to fighting lethal battles where you throw your exploding body at your opponent that you cannot wrap your head around a battle where the intricacy of your movements will determine victory alone."

Beelzebub flinched. Buddha's words were somewhat rude, but... when Beelzebub thought about it, the man had a point...

It might seem as though Buddha was handily handing Beelzebub his ass, but the ancient Hero knew far better than his opponent that an instant of inattentiveness would cost him his life. Despite his theatrics and provocative words, Buddha was taking Beelzebub as seriously as possible. He controlled his breathing underneath his helmet, but he also kept himself ready for many of the deadlier abilities in Beelzebub's arsenal.

"The intricacy of my movements...?" Beelzebub asked. "What does that even mean?"

"Every action has an equal and opposite reaction." Buddha explained calmly. "You reap what you sow. This is called **Karma**. When you extend your right arm to fire a bolt of lightning, it necessarily means that arm is momentarily locked in an attack position, exposing your right side to an attentive adversary's counter-attack. At the same time, you pay so much attention to your right arm that you fail to realize your left arm is hanging slackly at your side, doing nothing and leaving you vulnerable."

"That is why I said your movements are sloppy and uncoordinated." Buddha continued. "The only thing you are thinking about is knocking me to the ground. But do you think these are the same thoughts that occupy my mind?"

Beelzebub blinked. He couldn't bring himself to admit it out loud, but... Buddha had a point. Beelzebub had never taken any fighting lessons, and had spent most of his time just learning different ways of using his magic in battle. The physical capabilities of his body were always considered secondary, especially in recent years, when he had climbed the ranks of Baron, Duke, and Emperor. With his body regenerating horrifying wounds in seconds, he simply didn't care that much if he suffered a grievous counter-attack. His opponent would always come out worse!

In a battle of attrition and endurance, not one Sentient was his match!

"So what?" Beelzebub asked. "If I detonate my body next to you, you will die. That flimsy armor won't protect you."

"Perhaps not." Buddha said. "But what if your adversary was not me, an ordinary human, but someone much more powerful and frightening? What if they were exceptionally talented in martial combat, and capable of withstanding your suicidal attacks? What then?"

Beelzebub snorted. "Who would even fall into that category? Name one person."

Buddha stood up a little straighter.

"I'll name four." He said, while holding up four fingers. "Diablo in his Archdemon Form. Mephisto, with his unbreakable dragon bones. Divinator Fellrun. And Second Founder Dosena."

Beelzebub frowned. "Three of those people are dead. And right now, it seems Founder Dosena is in no condition to fight. I could kill her with a snap of my fingers."

"You're missing the point." Buddha countered. "Sentients capable of beating you already exist. More will reveal themselves in due time. You are not their match as you are now."

By now, Beelzebub had already lost much of his fighting spirit. He looked at Buddha with deep intent.

"So, what? You want to train me?"

"I'm still determining that." Buddha said. "You are a force of Chaos. If the current Envoy of Chaos should die, you are highly likely to succeed his position. This is not a good thing."

"Huh? Envoy of Chaos? Who- what??" Beelzebub asked in bewilderment.

"Gressil." Buddha replied. "He is the Emperor of Chaos, and the strongest agent of its will."

Sensing that Beelzebub no longer wished to fight, Buddha turned off his T-REX, then sat on a nearby boulder. He inhaled softly to catch his breath. After a moment's hesitation, Beelzebub walked over and sat next to him, looking as if he wanted to uncover more knowledge Buddha wished to bestow upon him.

"There are four Forces that govern our universe." Buddha said calmly. "Do you know what they are?"

Beelzebub slowly shook his head. "That sounds like some human science stuff. Gravity, magnets... something else?"

"No. The four forces are Karma, Chaos, Destiny, and Luck." Buddha explained. "Though Destiny has an inverse force named Fate."

Beelzebub started to nod, but when he realized he didn't understand what Buddha was saying, he thought better of it.

"I... don't follow."

"Karma is the fundamental force which states 'what goes around, comes around'." Buddha explained. "Chaos is the uncertainty principle. Neither are inherently good nor bad. The more one masters Karma, the more they can predict the future by observing the present. All actions lead to future reactions. If you strike with your right fist, that is an action which will lead to the reaction of your right fist momentarily not protecting your body."

"That seems simple enough. So Chaos is the opposite? Actions have no reaction?" Beelzebub asked.

"Not quite." Buddha said with a smile. "Chaos simply means that sometimes random variables will happen. It is true that unmaintained equipment will eventually break down, but the Chaos principle ensures even high quality and well-maintained equipment might spontaneously break down due to random negative events."

Buddha gave Beelzebub a look of warning. "A universe with too much Karma is a static, predictable universe. Chaos must always exist to provide a balance. But too much Chaos can lead to terrible instability. That is why these two forces are fundamentally opposed to one another."

He continued. "Destiny, also known as Fate, is similar to Karma. Some things are destined to happen, while other things are fated to pass. Destiny can accumulate to unleash great effects, while Fate may accumulate over time to unleash terrible effects. One is definitively positive, the other is definitively negative."

"That just sounds like Karma with a different name." Beelzebub replied.

"Karma is a singular event. Destiny and Fate accumulate over time." Buddha said. "For example, have you thought about the events which led to the fall of Maiura and Tarus II? Those two events could be seen as an accumulation of Fate over time which brought about the fall of humanity and the destruction of their homeworlds. Right now, humanity's Fate has reached a nexus point. Whether it continues to accumulate and worsen their future, or whether it reverses and begins to build to a greater Destiny... this will be determined by the Karma they reap."

Beelzebub scratched his head. "Oh... okay. I get it. I think. So what about Luck?"

"Luck is similar to Chaos." Buddha said, waving his hand to gesture at the world around them. "Chaos affects the world, but Luck affects living things. Chaos will bring ruin to a factory, but Luck can bring wealth or tragedy to the common man. A world without Luck and Chaos is a deterministic one that can only breed identical results from identical levels of effort. Those who master Luck and Chaos can greatly change the relative balance of the universe and its denizens."

Buddha sighed.

"I know these things may seem abstract. Indeed, few are aware of their pervasive influence. Only those who have gazed upon enough Truths may touch upon the fundamental principles, let alone manipulate them. Only those who have suffered terrible, terrible lives may obtain the power to manipulate Chaos."

Buddha looked at Beelzebub. "You, Beelzebub, have already manipulated Chaos once."

"I have??" Beelzebub asked, slightly stunned.

"When you detonated your body in the skies above Tarus II and killed a million humans, your rage caused you to tap into Chaos, momentarily neutralizing the fundamental force of magic. This prevented Jason Hiro from stopping your rampage. In the future, it is possible that if you fall further and further into darkness, you may once again inadvertently strengthen your bond with Chaos and take another step toward becoming its future Envoy."

"Does that mean Gressil and I would both become Emperors of Chaos?" Beelzebub asked.

"Each galaxy can only have one Envoy for each of the fundamental forces." Buddha said. "And that... is why I approached you today. If Gressil dies, you are most likely to be his successor. But it is possible to change your Destiny. Only if you are willing..."

Beelzebub seemed to realize something. "You... are an Envoy then?"

"The Envoy of Karma, yes." Buddha acknowledged.

"Then does that mean there are Envoys of Luck and Destiny as well?" Beelzebub prodded.

Buddha looked at the ground. He smiled.

"Indeed, our galaxy already has an Envoy of Luck. You know his name. But as for the Envoy of Destiny... he has passed away without a successor."

A moment of silence followed.

Beelzebub sucked in a breath.

"Wait. So. The Envoy of Destiny... was..."

"Jason Hiro." Buddha said quietly. "He accumulated an incredible Destiny, and an equally incredible Fate. Unfortunately, that Fate led to the fall of Maiura and the destruction of Tarus II. But as for the Destiny he accumulated..."

Buddha smiled and shook his head. "It has yet to bear fruit. The time is coming. Soon, it will sprout its first leaves."

"Who is the next successor of Destiny?" Beelzebub asked.

"Right now? There are several... Candidates." Buddha said slowly. "You are not one of them. The Chaos swirling around your body is too unsightly and dense to allow this.

However, if you were to disperse that aura of Chaos, it is possible you could become a Candidate for Destiny's Envoy."

Buddha slowly stood up. He wandered over to a tree and placed his hand on its trunk. He gazed at the tree with a strange mystic expression playing upon his face.

"Becoming an Envoy of Fate and Destiny is not something one can easily manipulate. Additionally, as you saw with Jason Hiro, it will inevitably lead to heartbreak and suffering."

He continued. "You would become capable of great feats that shock the world, but your eventual downfall would be as painful as it is glorious. Envoys of Destiny and Luck are not like Envoys of Karma and Chaos. The former cannot control their powers, while the latter can. I can use my powers of Karma to observe Cause and Effect. Gressil can use his powers to create pandemonium. But if you should become Destiny's Envoy, your life would no longer be fully within your control."

Beelzebub stayed silent for a moment.

"Are there other Candidates for this position right now?"

Buddha turned away from the tree to look off into the distance, across the forest and into the borders of Melodia.

"First, one must possess latent potential, or acquire it through hard work. Second, one must live up to their fullest capabilities. In doing so, they will begin to unlock their Fated Destiny. Third, they must continue to accumulate positive and negative Karma. Then, when the destined time has arrived, their accumulated Fate will release in all its splendor, causing incredible effects as far as the eye can see."

"So, to answer your question," Buddha said, meeting Beelzebub's gaze, "Yes. There are other Candidates. Anyone with latent potential who is capable of rising to meet that potential can become the Envoy. The clock is ticking. Time waits for no Sentient."

Beelzebub looked down at the ground. He fell completely silent for several minutes.

The sun slowly descended below the horizon until half of its body had become hidden, turning the red sky into a soft hue of pink.

"If I become the Envoy of Destiny, will I die?"

"Someday." Buddha said with a subtle nod. "But all Sentients die eventually. Whether your end comes sooner or later is determined by the Karma you reap."

That finally gave Beelzebub the information he wanted. Slowly, he stood up, then turned to face Buddha.

The two men stood, staring at one another. Beelzebub evaluated the man who had completely one-upped him in physical combat and ascetic knowledge. He still felt he could obliterate Buddha's existence with a wave of his hand, but if the two of them were at the same level of power, Beelzebub wouldn't stand a chance.

"...I'm not going to allow Chaos to decide my Destiny." Beelzebub finally said. "Can you teach me?"

Buddha closed his eyes.

"I teach any who are willing to learn."

Upon hearing this, Beelzebub knelt down on one knee and bowed his head.

"Then from now on... I will call you 'master.'"

"And I shall call you 'student.'" Buddha said solemnly. "Now rise. There is much work to do."

Part 656: Aevum Argent

January 27th, 2021.

Somewhere in the southern hemisphere of the Milky Way galaxy, a tiny blip of light streaked across the blackness of the Void at superliminal speeds. It raced toward the center of the galaxy, carefully avoiding the increasingly numerous and more densely packed stars until this was no longer easily possible.

After two days of travel time, Jason Hiro arrived at his destination.

At the center of the Milky Way, the density of stars became horrifying. In any given lightyear radius, instead of just one star, there would be as many as a million of them. This meant that once Jason reached a position close enough to the galactic center, the heat and light emitted would be so oppressive that he might end up instantly vaporized!

Luckily, he came prepared.

"I should be close enough. No need to go any further." Jason said to himself.

A powerful force field surrounded the Wordsmith. All alone, without even Mildred by his side, the Wordsmith stealthily stole away from Earth and traveled here for one important reason.

It was finally time!

It was time to create Chrona's successor!

Ever since he formulated his plan to save the Earth, creating a new Chrona was the lynchpin of his future success. Unfortunately, until he had successfully upgraded his brain, he hadn't possessed the acumen to accomplish such a feat.

But now, after ingesting millions of books into his GenesisFrame MindCore, he finally had the capability to develop his initial framework.

"Chrona had too many flaws." Jason said to himself as he tapped his chin. "Looking back, it's obvious those flaws were caused by my shoddy design skills. I never managed to stabilize the timeflow, so it was always slowly speeding up as time went on. This level of sloppiness simply won't do for its successor."

"Another problem is that Chrona's design was extremely unfocused. I just built whatever I needed at the time wherever there was room. This led to a disorganized secret dimension that had inefficiencies galore. I cannot let the next one be so pathetic!"

Jason looked ahead of himself. Far in the distance, the stellar background luminosity was so bright that it was as if he were looking at a million suns in the night sky. Without his specialized force field blocking 99.9% of the light, his irises would have burned out instantly.

"This new realm will be known as..."

Jason paused.

"**Aevum.**"

The word came to him in a flash of inspiration.

Aevum. It was an ancient word that invoked time, eternality, and a sense of stillness. It had many connotations, and all of them were to Jason's liking.

"Aevum. That shall be the name of my new star-empire."

Jason smiled. He had considered bringing Hideki along, but this initial part would probably bore him. Better to amaze his father later, once Aevum had been finalized.

Naturally, Jason did not need to think too hard on how Aevum would be built. He had already spent the last two days doing so as he flew to the galactic center; an eternity when it came to the new capabilities of his MindCore.

"**Form! Condense! Expand! Tear!**"

Jason rapidly began speaking tens of Words of Power, manipulating and tearing the space in front of himself. Here, less than 500 lightyears from the galactic core, there were no habitable worlds within a galactic stone's throw, and it would be practically impossible for even the Volgrim to uncover his base. If they really put their minds to it, doing so might be possible, but he was absolutely certain it would be harder than finding Chrona, which he had anchored to a planet in his previous timeline.

Within just a few minutes, an invisible dimension had already taken form. Jason ripped apart space far more efficiently for Aevum than he ever could have done for Chrona. His previous MindCore was focused on predictions, not on construction and blueprints. Thus, the GenesisFrame allowed him to accomplish in seconds what would have previously taken minutes... if not hours.

A moment later, Jason teleported inside the new dimensional tear.

The stars in the sky vanished. He arrived inside total darkness.

Jason looked around. He pondered for a moment.

"Last time, I manually accelerated the temporal factor by repeating the same Word of Power a thousand times. Gah! My old self was... *a peasant*! Such a stupid way of doing things. And it also led to an inconsistent temporal plane! I won't make such a mistake this time."

Instead of accelerating the timespace, Jason completely skipped this step. He began creating spatial anchors, infinitely tiny nodes of energy that drew from the stellar energy outside of Aevum to stabilize its internal space. These anchors would only be temporary, as later they would be greatly improved upon.

Slowly, Jason began 'pushing' Aevum's internal dimensional space outward. Bit by bit, meter by meter, he forcibly stabilized the space until he was able to create a simple ball of dirt beneath his feet.

With 'solid ground' to stand on, the basic initial step of Aevum's formation had begun. It had a stable inner space, and a tiny 'world' no bigger than Jason's body.

Jason held out his palm face-up.

"**Crystal!**"

A single orb materialized above his palm. This orb was the most important component of Aevum. In the future, it would be its greatest strength, and its greatest weakness. If enemies were able to invade and target it, the entire dimension was likely to collapse and destroy everything within.

Jason shrugged. "I'll just have to make sure nobody can find this place."

In his hands rested the central control matrix of his future Empire. The Nexus Crystal was the key to achieving all of his plans. It was made from Wordsmithium, an element he was all-too-familiar with, and thus was essentially unbreakable except by Cosmic entities. It had the unique ability to collect and divert a seemingly infinite amount of energy. It could also control spatial laws...

Jason levitated the Nexus Crystal above his head. He manipulated it with a few Words of Power, and all of a sudden, a beam of light pierced the spatial barrier surrounding Aevum, its power directed into the Nexus Crystal.

"Bingo." Jason said to himself with a smile.

The Nexus Crystal began to light up as the power of a star flowed from outside Aevum into its interior.

This was its most important function. Much like the star-collection array from Chrona, Jason needed a way to acquire, process, and control massive amounts of energy. He could create fusion reactors, but those were only useful on a planetary scale. What he needed was enough energy to power a future Empire!

Thus, the Nexus Crystal could breach the dimensional wall and draw power from the outside galaxy.

With that in mind, Jason's next tasks began to flow much faster. He attached energy connections to the spatial anchors, drastically increasing their power and allowing the dimensional walls to grow faster than ever.

He created a Planetary Core inside the tiny ball of dirt beneath his feet, causing it to rapidly expand along with Aevum's dimensional space once the Nexus Crystal attached a transmission point.

It only took Jason thirty minutes and Aevum's internal space had already reached half of Chrona's when it was first made, but he only used a fraction of his original effort. If he had stupidly expanded the space using manual Wordsmithing, he'd have expended far more energy for far less gain.

"Alright, it seems the internal expansion has started to slow." Jason said out loud. "Now for the second step."

Jason focused his GenesisFrame. He summoned a schematic into his mind's eye, one he had crafted on the trip to the center of the galaxy.

"**Materialize.**"

He held out his hand, and a second crystal appeared. This one was not white like the Nexus Crystal, but was instead pure black, capable of absorbing any light that came into contact with it.

"Alright. The Temporal Crystal is done." Jason said.

He levitated it downward, and it sank inside the micro-planet that had formed beneath his feet. Once it reached the center, it merged with the beam of energy transmitted by the Nexus Crystal.

At that moment, the temporal laws began to shift.

Jason vaguely felt the world altering around himself. The flow of Aevum's internal time rapidly adjusted from a 1:1 ratio with the outside galaxy to a 10:1 ratio. Then a 25:1 ratio. Then 50:1...

Without Jason ever needing to use manual Wordsmithing, the flow of time changed gradually until it eventually froze at a very specific number.

"Temporal dilation complete. I just gained a lot of time." Jason said with a smile.

Unlike Chrona, which initially solidified at a 250:1 time ratio, Aevum was much faster, at 365:1, but also far more stable.

One year inside Aevum meant one day on Earth. It was more convenient to synchronize with Earth's chronometer than Volgarius or some other world, and it meant that Jason would always be able to know the date and time in the outer universe.

Aevum's chronometer was completely stable, neither accelerating nor speeding up. Once Jason finished his work, he thought to himself about the Hall of Heroes.

"I bet Solomon had a hand in helping Hope make the Hall of Heroes. He wasn't as ambitious as me, but he probably built a temporal crystal or matrix of some sort to regulate the time-flow. It's a shame I didn't do the same thing back then, but here we are now."

With the temporal and spatial laws finally solidified, Jason began to accelerate his work.

He added more energy relays to Aevum, causing the Nexus Crystal to absorb more power and spread it out to more areas.

He replaced the spatial anchors with biological ones that used magical principles to stabilize and grow Aevum's internal space, rather than requiring external energy. This small improvement made it so even if the Nexus Crystal was sabotaged or destroyed, Aevum would not collapse immediately and its residents could escape.

Not long afterward, Jason's eyes glowed with power as he channeled the Nexus Crystals' energy into himself.

"**CONSTRUCT!**"

A schematic inside his mind manifested into reality. A massive spire shaped like the Eiffel Tower appeared atop the rocky world below. The spire started out wide at the bottom, but rapidly narrowed into a skinny pole-like shape at the top, where the Nexus Crystal was embedded.

This tower was not only a marvel to look at, with its black exterior and smooth sheen, but it also served a practical purpose. Lines of energy streamed down the tower, wrapping in circles around its shaft and spreading outward like a spiderweb across the slowly forming planet.

These energy lines were termed 'Leylines' by Jason. Not only did they harness the power of the outer cosmos, but later he intended for them to simultaneously transmit magical energy as well.

At the base of the Nexus Tower, Jason conjured a special micro-dimension. This dimension harnessed a massive amount of power to form a singularity that defied common sense. He created a bedroom where he could sleep... and inside that bedroom, time completely froze! The moment he stepped inside, he would step right back out afterward.

This completely defied the laws of physics, and was only possible because of his MindCore granting him incredible new creation abilities.

"What happened with Hope will never happen again." Jason muttered to himself.

He had beaten Hope, but each time Jason needed to sleep and had Fiona or Rebecca take over his drones, Hope gained a huge advantage, and nearly won the battle when he directly exploited it.

Jason could never let this happen again. His combat capabilities were lower, his mental perception of time was slower, and if the him of now fought the Hope of back then, he might lose!

...But that was only if he were to fight with Chrona as his home turf. With Aevum, he now held the complete advantage.

Jason's eyes momentarily dimmed.

"**The Stillness**. It will change the galactic situation more than anyone can imagine."

That was the term he chose for this time-frozen room. It wasn't big enough for him to do any serious work, but he would have time to think, to plan, and to sleep whenever he

needed it.

Jason turned his attention elsewhere. He forcibly increased the speed of Aevum's expansion, making it larger and larger until it had noticeably surpassed Chrona's initial size. He continued to funnel the power of additional stars into the Nexus Tower, which he used to build more and more facilities.

A circular wall appeared. It surrounded the center of Aevum's main city, which he titled **Argent**. At the moment, Argent would be the only city within Aevum, but who could know if more would become viable, or even necessary later?

The Great Barrier of Argent enveloped the future city with a protective shield that completely swallowed its interior. Not only were the walls made of Wordsmithium, but they also projected a circular barrier above and below Argent's borders, ensuring no enemy could go under or below the walls to reach its interior.

But, a casual observer might ask, *why* did Jason need to protect the city?

Jason's eyes glowed with power. He reached toward the distance and conjured a small mountain. This mountain began to grow, and grow, and grow some more.

Argent was a surprisingly large city, with over fifty kilometers of square internal space.

But the mountain Jason summoned was colossal. It rose into the sky, its caldera opening to reveal a massive pool of blue liquid within its maw. The mountain grew more and more, eventually stretching ten kilometers into the sky! Its base was ten times Argent's size, and with only twenty-five kilometers of distance separating the mountain from Argent, it felt like a Titan was looking down upon an ant.

Jason looked up at the mountain.

"**Axis Mundi.**" Jason said as he looked upon the highest peak, his words evoking a feeling of ancient awe inside his heart. "The Cradle of Life. The Primal Wellspring. If The Nexus Tower is the pillar that holds Aevum together, then Axis Mundi is the lifeblood that will fuel its future!"

He grinned. His excitement was so infectious that anyone nearby would have grinned as well.

Nobody but Jason knew his plans for Aevum. In his mind's eye, Axis Mundi was the conceptual masterpiece that made the entire dimension function properly. Without it, Aevum would lose three quarters of its future potential.

Jason waved his hand. Plants began sprouting outside the Great Barrier. A forest emerged. Lakes, rivers, and streams. On the opposite side of the world as the city of Argent, a deep ocean took form.

Lifeless though the world might be, Jason had formed the beginning of a seed that would someday germinate into the Milky Way's base of power.

If his plans bore fruit, the Volgrim would never be able to defeat him. He would gain a foundation so formidable that even the Founders would be forced to kneel if they wished to preserve their lives.

"I alone am not enough to save humanity." Jason said to himself. "I know that now. I tried to do it all alone before. I failed. Because of me, my wife died. Even if my daughter lived, that was only a fluke of luck. I will never again risk the lives of the people I love! I will grant power to all who are worthy! I will uplift humanity itself, and together, we will gain the strength to beat back those dogs of Hell, those aliens who think themselves our betters!"

Jason waved his hand. A massive crack split open Axis Mundi, followed by several more. Primal blue fluid rushed from the mountain's interior. It poured down the mountainside, spilled into the valley below, and rapidly carved out new rivers and streams.

This liquid was not ordinary water, but Genesis Ichor... the Water of Life!

As it flowed down into the woodlands, rivers, and lakes below, the Genesis Ichor began to immediately create strange effects on the environment. Plants abruptly mutated when they absorbed the Ichor. They grew larger and more lush, gained elemental attributes, and even occasionally gained minor intelligence.

These were only the initial effects. Jason knew that, in time, the mutations would grow more and more pronounced!

"I'd better make sure to warn future visitors and residents *not* to drink the water outside the walls." Jason joked to himself.

Jason summoned various animals into the Ironwoods outside the Great Barrier. Interestingly, he mostly only summoned herbivore animals, especially rabbits. They bred quickly, and time was of great importance in these early phases.

He summoned birds, including parakeets, crows, pigeons, eagles, hawks, and many more. He summoned mice and rats. He conjured cats and dogs outside the walls, and allowed them to roam free.

In just a few years time, the Genesis Ichor would rapidly mutate the creatures he had placed down. Jason was extremely eager to see how Aevum would develop.

He finally turned away from the outer region to look up at the sky. He summoned a star to orbit Aevum, an artificial source of solar energy and light, powered by the Nexus Crystal and guided by the Temporal Crystal. As Aevum continued to steadily expand over time, these two crystals would ensure the star above would not fall toward the planet and obliterate the city. It would maintain a steady size, distance, and speed.

Jason's eyes glowed with magical power. He conjured buildings and facilities inside Argent's borders, facilities with a deep purpose that would allow him to build toward his ultimate goal of empowering humanity. He created lodgings for Argent's future residents, factories to build weapons and technology, and he even conjured an extremely special floating prism in the sky.

Jason looked up at the truck-sized prism. He sent it flying up into the air, where it reached the edge of Aevum's spatial wall. The prism flew into the path of the Nexus Tower's energy line, causing it to split into hundreds of individual beams of light. These beams all pierced the spatial wall at different angles, but the overall intent was to more accurately and efficiently focus external energy into the Nexus Tower.

Now came the most important step of all. With Aevum's spatial walls hardened beyond belief, Jason took charge of the Nexus Crystal and the Temporal Crystal. He began moving Aevum through space, slowly flying it toward the galactic center.

That's right. His goal was not to position Aevum outside the galactic center, but directly inside it. This was the most dangerous place to attack, but the safest place to defend! As long as Aevum didn't collapse under the gravitational force of the Milky Way's central black hole, Aevum's future was assured.

But it would take a long, long time to fully move Aevum where it needed to go. Jason wasn't too worried. Moving the dimension needed to happen slowly anyway, to allow Aevum to adapt to the gravitational pressure engulfing the galactic center.

As it happened, Chrona could not be moved. This was due to Jason's inexperience in creating folded spaces. Aevum could, but that was because he deliberately made it

possible. The Nexus Crystal made many things possible he couldn't have imagined before.

* * *

Somewhere in the Southern Quadrant of the Milky Way, a certain Psion lifted her head. She paused her meditation and looked around with a frown.

[Hmm?]

Founder Dosena narrowed her eyes. For a brief instant, she sensed something frightening near the Milky Way's core, but the feeling vanished as quickly as it came.

She continued to stare toward the center of the Milky Way, but that momentary feeling of horror didn't return.

After a long, long hour of staring, she closed her eyes and returned to her meditation.

It was only her imagination...

Part 657: Operation Birdcage

January 27th, 2021, Earth, USA.

A tiny dot of light streaked across the United States of America from the west coast to the east coast. It moved in singular bursts of straight lines with momentary pauses between each movement, and each flicker of movement itself occurred at the speed of light. This dot of light sent bursts of lightning scattering in all directions at the start of its movement, and at the end.

After traveling the length of the USA, it then spun around and raced back the other direction. Despite its brilliant light and shocking movement speed, it barely drew any attention. Satellites were not able to keep up with it, and ground-based radar only noticed a flicker of energy before that flicker instantly disappeared.

As it returned to the west coast from whence it started, it charged toward the base of Mount Whitney in California, the tallest mountain in the USA outside of Alaska. In the blink of an eye, it snapped up to the peak and exploded with energy, obliterating a small group of humans that had recently climbed to the mountaintop a few hours before, annihilating them before they could register what happened.

This 'blip' of lightning turned out to be none other than Emperor Ose. She breathed evenly and looked around the world in a 360-degree radius, hardly noticing and definitely not caring that her arrival had blasted apart a handful of men and women who had just scaled the peak for fun. Their deaths meant nothing to her.

Ose wrinkled her nose at the blood and gore that now stained Whitney's peak, then focused her eyes to the northwest. Her body fired off across the sky and she traveled more than two hundred kilometers in the blink of an eye, arriving back at Crescent City, CA, where her home base was located.

Ose struck the ground outside the city limits and skidded to a stop, electrical energy crackling around her. She adjusted her neck, dusted off her white dress suit, and stood up a little straighter.

It seems my ascension to Emperor has not enhanced my maximum speed at all. I am firmly locked to instantaneous bursts of lightspeed. Ose thought to herself. *I cannot turn when transmitting myself, and I can only move in straight lines. However, my tolerance*

for rapid-transmissions has increased greatly. I can chain bursts with ninety percent less downtime than when I was a Baron.

Ose looked around. She found a random cliff-face nearby, then zipped over to it with a flicker of lightning.

On arrival, she assumed a fighting posture. Then she began throwing kicks and punches as quickly as possible at the cliff-face.

Boom-boom-boom!

She held back much of her Emperor-level strength, not wanting to obliterate the mountain, but even so, her speed was fast enough to leave after-images. She struck the mountain ten times every second, her fists and legs leaving massive imprints on the cliff's bare wall.

After a full minute of unrelenting offense, she stopped and assessed the damage.

My striking power is roughly 100 times greater than when I was a Baron. Before, I could pick up and throw a small vehicle with a bit of strain, but now I can lift one of the humans' heaviest tanks with contemptuous ease and throw it multiple miles into the distance. My striking speed is faster, but only because my inner strength has been enhanced. I can finally keep up with the strain my lightning powers put on my body.

Ose turned away from the cliffside. She started running as quickly as she could, charging into the distance without actually flickering her body around at the speed of light.

Before long, she found an empty back road with only dirt and no cars on it. Using this as a makeshift race track, she accelerated to her fastest possible speed. Her feet lightly tapped the ground, leaving no imprints, and she pitter-pattered across the dirt while only causing the sound of buzzing insects to emanate outward.

That's it? Only about 200 miles (321 KPH) per hour? Ose thought, frowning to herself. Her ordinary running speed was fast, but nowhere near as fast as her instantaneous flickers.

Ose reached the end of the dirt road, spun on her toes, then rushed back the same way she came. This time, she deliberately struck the ground with her feet as hard as she could. This caused rapid explosive sounds to blast outward, which startled all the local wildlife and increased her speed by another fifty percent. She realized that if she opted to go loud

and intimidating instead of somewhat stealthy, she could increase her running speed by another level!

Ose skidded to a stop at the top of the dirt road. She turned to look behind herself at the massive potholes she had left in her wake. Unfortunately, any humans who encountered this road in the future would be left bewildered by the state it was in, wondering if Bigfoot had stomped through here recently.

If I want to traverse great distances, my instantaneous flickers are still the best. But if I want relatively fast speeds along with maneuverability, my top speed without flicker-movement is pitifully low.

Ose mentally chastised herself, but if any other demons were to hear her inner thoughts, their heads might explode in rage! Even Belial, who was quite fast when she sprinted, could only top out at 100 miles per hour, less than half Ose's speed. Almost all the other demons were slower than that.

After thinking for a bit, Ose flickered away and traveled into a nearby forest. She disappeared into its greenery, sliced at a tree with the side of her hand, and felled it to make a perfectly flat stump. She sat down in the lotus position with her legs crossed, then closed her eyes and began to think.

My body's fault tolerance capabilities have shot way up. My striking strength is higher than ever. I can maneuver and fight in the big leagues now. Perhaps if I fight that Archseer again, I can quickly kill him. However, one must never underestimate a Trueborn. He won't fool me so easily.

My biggest problem is that even though I can speed up and slow down my perception of time, I cannot be both fast and slow at the same time. This is a critical vulnerability I must immediately ameliorate! If my perception speed is fast, I can sense danger but cannot converse normally with other Sentients. But if it is slow, I cannot sense danger and incoming sneak attacks. It would be most pitiful if that Cat Mask managed to assassinate me with a well-timed sniper round! Hmm. Is it possible to achieve both at the same time? Can I somehow become both fast and slow?

Of course I can! This is a matter most simple to execute.

Ose focused her mental energies. After less than a minute, her Mind Realm began to distort. Then... it split in two!

Two halves, each one equally Ose, became capable of perceiving the world. They quickly entered internal dialogue with one another.

[I shall be the Primary.]

[I shall be the Secondary.]

[Secondary, how should we split control of the Main Body?]

[Perhaps as Primary you should always be in control. I should only take control when I detect a threat.]

A few minutes passed.

[This arrangement will not work, Secondary. If I am controlling the Main Body, you are not. You cannot control the eyes or limbs.]

[Noted. It seems rapidly switching control is not possible either. I attempted to switch with you but failed. My perception is currently set to 1000x realtime speed, but because yours is set to 1x realtime speed, I am forced to slow down to your level when attempting the Main Body control transfer.]

[This is inefficient. If we come under threat, even a single second is more time than we can afford to swap control, Secondary.]

[Agreed. Let us think of another solution.]

This time, a full five minutes passed. Both halves of Ose's brain accelerated their perception of time to the absolute maximum speed, a full 1,000,000x realtime speed. For each second that passed in reality, a million passed inside her Mind Realm. Thus, five million minutes, or approximately ten years, passed inside her Mind Realm. They constantly discussed many different solutions. But eventually, they settled on one.

[Archangel Michael is indeed a good example of this theory in practice. Very well. Secondary, you will assume total control of the right arm, and partial control of the waist. As Primary, I will control the rest of the body and rely on you for momentary instantaneous defense before swapping total control during a battle scenario.]

[I have another idea, Primary. Since we have already split once, why not split again?]

[Again? To what end?]

[We should create a Tertiary to focus on cerebral pursuits. Tertiary will not control any part of the body, but will instead focus on research and development.]

[I see. So I will control the main body for ordinary conversations and world perception, you will focus on defense against sneak attacks, and Tertiary will focus on R&D. This is a sensible choice. We shall test it now.]

Another minute passed. Ose's Mind Realm vibrated rapidly, and a slow, tentative split occurred.

[My designation is Tertiary.]

[This second Mind Realm split was extremely painful, Secondary. This should be the limit of our splitting.]

[Agreed, Primary. Additionally, my mental perception has slowed dramatically. It seems the three of us share our perception speeds when we are not synchronized equally. It is not possible for myself and Tertiary to both possess high level mental acceleration while Primary is at a lower dilation. We must split the acceleration unevenly.]

[I have a suggestion.] Tertiary said. [I will exist in a state of 10,000x normalspeed. Secondary will only operate at 100x normalspeed. Primary will exist at 2x Normalspeed.]

[2x? Why not 1x?] Primary asked.

[2x Normalspeed is still sufficient for conversing with other Sentients, it does not slow down time to a disagreeable level, and it allows the Main Body to still react twice as quickly as usual. This is an excellent balance between the three Selves.] Tertiary said.

[I agree.] Secondary responded. [I could operate at 1000x Normalspeed, but the difference between 100x and 1000x is relatively minor. Tertiary needs all the speed for R&D that she can acquire. This new system strikes a delicate balance.]

[Noted.] Primary replied. [It seems any further splits are impossible or will provide no real value. We will exist in a tri-brained state.]

[We must also consider the different 'states' of our intelligence.] Secondary mentioned. [We only have so much bandwidth available. Primary, you will focus on charisma and conversation-driven intelligence. Tertiary, you will focus on abstract and high-level thinking. As for myself, I will focus on combat sense and threat detection.]

[Agreed.] Primary said.

[Agreed.] Tertiary said.

[We are all in agreement.] Secondary said. [For now, this is how things shall be done. Perhaps we may adjust the ratios and cerebral states later.]

In less than thirty minutes, Ose underwent a fundamental change in abilities that nobody in the galaxy could have predicted. Even Jason had no idea she had completely reinvented herself.

Jason was completely oblivious to the new Threat he had awakened. The Ose he fought in the future was a very different Ose from the one during humanity's peak. Her much older self had lived for over 100,000 years, triumphed against humanity during the Energy Wars, and accomplished many great feats long after humanity's fall. When she became Emperor, it was at a time when demonkind ruled over humanity's last remnants, and she naturally suffered from a huge ego, thinking that defeating the humans and their barely worthy Hero would be a simple matter. Ultimately, it was her arrogance and ego that led to her undoing.

But the Ose of the past was not the same as her older self. She was used to fighting against a powerful humanity that possessed a vast military force. The angels and Titans were still alive. Threats to demonkind's future lurked in abundance. She was thus forced to act with greater caution and shrewdness. She immediately realized that facing against not one but multiple Heroes was a far more difficult challenge than facing 'only' Jason Hiro in the future. Even if the Archseer was young and stupid, it was abundantly clear that Cat Mask was a major threat, let alone the supporting capabilities of all the other Ancestral Spirits.

The moment Ose finished her new preparations, she jumped to her feet and looked around. The world around her now moved at half its normal speed, at least according to the perception of her Primary Brain. Her Secondary Brain now controlled her right arm, and its perception slowed reality down to 1% of its normal speed. Her Tertiary Brain could not perceive the world at all, but it slowed time down to 0.001% of normal speed. Each minute that passed in reality was 10,000 minutes inside her Tertiary Brain.

From this moment on, Ose would be operating at a level far above what the humans were expecting.

It's a shame I can't just magic things into reality. Ose thought to herself glumly. *Even if I design new weapons constantly, I'll still have to fabricate them by hand. That's another inefficiency I'll have to work out later.*

She looked up into the sky, and her body became a blur of light as she shot into the horizon.

January 27th, 2021, New York City.

Satan stood in his office, looking out the windows at the distant Central Park. He clasped his hands behind his back as he thought about a great many things.

[The new girl is quite interesting.] A voice said within his head. [Verily, she hath awakened my interest.]

"Yeah. She ain't bad." Satan replied. "To think she's already noticed so many things... if she's right, we've got a real problem on our hands."

Satan's Vectors manipulated a cigar, lifting and lighting it before placing it in his mouth. Satan took a long drag, and his eyes fogged over for a moment.

"We need to accelerate the timeline. Keep these humans guessing." Satan said slowly.

[Is it finally time for Operation Birdcage?]

"Hehe. It might be, *Hades*."

Hades, formerly known as Archangel Samael, lurked within Satan's Mind Realm. Unlike all Satan's other souls, he was able to operate with impunity, working alongside the Devil to advance their collective interests of overthrowing and someday slaughtering all the angels.

Nobody hated the angels more than Hades. Their ancient betrayal of his beloved sisters, Muriel and Cassiel, had long ago fallen into a distant memory, but its pain had never lessened.

And of all the angels, the one he hated most was undoubtedly Raphael.

[We cannot construct the new Hell until we hath obtained Valac's Lantern.] Hades pointed out. [Brother Satan, tis' unwise to allow any further delays. Each day that passes, more humans join the Lazarite's ranks.]

Satan snorted. "Lazarites? They ain't shit. They're nothing more than meatshields. I can kill a thousand of them with a wave of my hand."

[I fear thou mayest be underestimating them.] Hades said, a hint of warning in his tone. [Dost thou thinketh Raphael a simpleton? There may yet be a secret power they

have yet to reveal.]

Satan didn't take his warning to heart. "Secret power? You're paranoid. Demon Lords stomp the life out of Lazarites. We've seen it time and again. Lazarites are barely above the average Demon Grunt, and are definitely weaker than our strongest Grunts. We ain't got anything to fear."

[I hope the reality art as thou believeth.] Hades said, withdrawing his thoughts afterward.

Several minutes passed. Satan glanced around his office, frowning as he thought about the 'bugs' Ose had told him about. Had more cropped up after she swept it clean? He wasn't certain. He definitely didn't trust that the office was secure anymore, but he'd spent so many years living here that it felt uncomfortable thinking about leaving and going elsewhere just to have a private discussion.

Satan tapped into one of his powers, a Warper soul inside his body. He summoned a portal, then stepped through it and arrived elsewhere in the United States, somewhere in the midwest, deep underground. There, a small horde of demons jumped when they saw his unexpected arrival.

Satan closed the portal behind himself. He looked around at the demons present, which consisted mainly of undead Grunts, Lords, and even a Baron or two. One still-living demon levitated toward him, the demon's skinless head covered by a cloak.

"Emperor Satan. This is an unexpected surprise."

"Baron Ozzar." Satan said perfunctorily. "Is Mephisto around?"

"The Duke of Mist is currently dealing with a minor matter. I will summon him for you, First Emperor." Ozzar said, bowing his head. Green smoke burped from his mouth as he quickly turned and floated away.

A few minutes later, Ozzar returned with Mephisto, though the Duke of Mist took the lead.

"Sssatan. Hasss sssomething happened?" Mephisto hissed, his bloody red eyes shining out of his skull sockets.

"Did anyone tell you about the Trueborns that popped up?" Satan asked.

Mephisto nodded slightly, but his next words somewhat contradicted that action. "I have heard a little regarding their appearancesss. The detailsss, however, have eluded

me."

"I'll make it short and sweet then." Satan said. "We're dealing with two Trueborn for the first time in history. A father and son. The father's name is unknown, but he goes by the moniker 'Cat Mask.' The son's name is Jason Hiro, but he calls himself the Archseer. Based on recovered recon info and Emperor Ose's efforts, we have a pretty good idea of what their powers are."

"Emperor Ossse?" Mephisto asked, cocking his head. "I do not recognizzze that name."

"Remember Lucy's girl, Ose? Baron Ose?" Satan asked, while Mephisto nodded his head. "She did me a big favor, so I promoted her to Emperor. She has lightning and technology powers. Some other stuff. Pretty strong. Anyway, she fought both Trueborn while she was only a Baron and kicked their asses. Couldn't kill 'em, but she gave us a lot of intel."

He continued. "Cat Mask seems to have some sort of super-reaction powers, along with teleportation, enhanced strength, and durability. Right now, we think the latter two aren't actually his. A different Hero must have boosted him somehow. He also has a crazy strong gun that shoots bullets even Lilia couldn't tank. He singlehandedly took down Lucy, so he's a big threat."

"Then we've got his son, the Archseer. Jason seems less imposing, but never take a Trueborn lightly. Recovered intel says his power is called 'Dream Eating'. He can see into the future like a precog, he has advanced weapon training, and he's just as strong and durable as his dad. Once again, those last two are likely abilities given by one of the Ancestral Spirits."

"Two Trueborn... thisss isss a troublesssome development." Mephisto said uneasily. "Doesss thisss mean you're here to...?"

"Yeah. It's time." Satan said. "I know we were planning on waiting five or ten more years, but perfect is the enemy of good enough. Operation Birdcage has to happen sooner rather than later."

Mephisto didn't say anything for a few moments. He rubbed his skeletal hands together, making a discomforting grinding noises when bone scraped against bone.

"Troublesssome. Very, very troublesssome." Mephisto repeated twice. "Sssatan, the preparationsss are not complete. Our agentsss are not ready. There isss a twenty-five

percccent chance of failure if we act now."

"It might not be that high." Satan said, rubbing his chin. "I'm gonna fill Ose in on the deets. I want you ready to act within three days. Our deadline is the 30th. Got it?"

Mephisto threw up his hands. "You are the bosss. I do asss you command."

"Good. I'm gonna rope a couple extra Emperors in. If we don't have the quantity, we'll make up for it with quality. As long as you can slip into the Tower, the mission is as good as complete."

That seemed to settle Mephisto's nerves. He relaxed a little and nodded deeply.

"We will be ready within three daysss."

Satan nodded back. He opened a portal back to his office, then stepped through.

After the portal closed, Satan donned his human form, then stepped out where his secretaries were. Belial was not among them.

"I'm gonna be taking a business trip for the next week. Clear my calendar."

"Yes, Mister Hercule."

Part 658: President Steven Johannesburg

January 27th, 2021. 9 AM. Washington DC, USA. White House.

President Steven Johannesburg sat heavily in his luxurious black leather office chair behind the Resolute Desk, where many small stacks of papers sat arranged before him. He had only assumed office for a week, and already, his 'day one' campaign promises were knocking at the door. Unlike his two predecessors, he had sworn not to rule by Executive Order, so he had to do things the old fashioned way; by cold-calling Senators, House Representatives, and other high level lawmakers to try and push his agenda through.

It had only been seven days since January 20th, but he was already feeling that the next four years, possibly the next eight, would be the longest years of his life.

His wife, Jolene Johannesburg, stepped into the office. Her brown hair was in a prim and proper bun, and she wore a pressed blue suit with a cute hat. Her eyes sparkled in that way they always did when she looked at him.

"You're heading out?" Steven asked, sending her a tired smile.

"I have that meeting with Senator Woodram, remember? It's already nine, dear." Jolene said, walking over and giving him a kiss on the cheek. "I sent the boys over to the country club to mingle with their friends. They'll be back home around eight PM tonight."

"Oh, good, good." Steven said, kissing her back. "I'll see you later then, honey."

Jolene started to pull away, but then she hesitated and frowned.

"Steven, I know it's hectic, but you should take a break. You look awful."

"I have some golf planned with Governor Kratsky later." Steven replied.

"No, not golf. Golf is 'social work.' It's shmoozing. I mean you should take an eight-hour nap." Jolene said disapprovingly. "You could hide a cat inside those bags under your eyes."

Steven rubbed his eyes. "I'll nap when I'm dead, sweetheart."

"That's what your father always said, and look where that got him." Jolene grumbled. "See you later."

She stole out of the office, and Steven heaved a sigh. He sat down at his desk and tiredly looked over his itinerary.

"Sleep. Yeah. Wouldn't that be nice..." He mumbled to himself. "Christ, and I have a photoshoot with the local basketball team at noon. Is that really the best use of my time? Maybe I should ask Kelly to scrap it. No, that would make me look too dismissive. The press would eat me alive."

He licked his fingers, then flipped through several folders on his desk. One of the folders was labeled 'Marine Preservation Act 2022' and another was labeled 'Security Detail Review January 2021'. There were many of these papers scattered around, and all of them demanded some level of his attention.

After fifteen minutes, the phone on his desk rang. He flicked the speakerphone button.

"Yes, Kelly?"

A woman's voice spoke over the phone. "Mister President, your Secretary of Defense wants to meet with you. He has a visitor with him. He said something about a national security threat."

What's that fat bastard up to now? Steven silently wondered, thinking of his Secretary of Defense, Chris Brisker. He was a relatively ugly and morbidly obese man, not particularly qualified for the job, but in order to win a couple key voter demographics, Steven had to bring Chris into his cabinet. He cringed at the thought.

"Yeah, alright, send them in, Kelly." Steven said, quickly rubbing his eyes to wake himself up.

After a few seconds, the door opened. Chris walked in and spread out his arms. "Hey, Steven! Good to see ya!"

"Yeah. Good to see you too." Steven replied, much more evenly.

His eyes strayed to Chris's left, where a thirty-something man with white hair was standing, holding a conspicuously large black briefcase. Oddly, he wore sunglasses despite being indoors.

"And this... suspicious looking fellow is...?" Steven asked, prodding his somewhat slow and dim-witted subordinate for info.

Chris nodded, causing his jowls to flap. "Oh, this guy here, he says his code name is Agent Silver. Works for the FBI."

"Not the FBI." Agent Silver said. "I work for a highly classified subdivision of the US Military. Mister Brisker, thank you for seeing me in. You may leave now."

Chris blinked. He frowned, not liking Silver's remark. "Hey, watch the tone, pal. You don't order me around."

"I outrank you." Silver said, barely even looking at him before walking over to the president's desk. He sat down without being offered, then paused for half a breath.

Steven looked at the man with the sunglasses. He felt there was something... strange about him.

"Chris, you can go. Thank you for bringing Silver in here." Steven said, smiling perfunctorily at the man.

"Well, alright then. I know when three's a crowd!" Chris said, in that whiney tone he always used when he wasn't getting what he wanted. Despite his ulterior motives, he still left the room and closed the door.

A few moments passed. Steven Johannesburg eyed the man calmly sitting across from his with several reservations.

"What branch of the military are you in?" Steven asked.

"No need to ask questions, Mister President." Agent Silver said, finally pulling down his glasses. When Steven saw the man's eyes, he was surprised. Even his irises were silver, like his hair. "I'm here to onboard you, now that your hectic first week has concluded."

"Onboard me." Steven repeated. "To what?"

Silver looked Steven in the eyes. He smiled, but there was no warmth in the expression.

"Now that you have assumed office over the most powerful military on Planet Earth, your true responsibilities have begun. I have many Truths to reveal to you, Truths which the average person and 99.9% of all high-level politicians are not privy to. As President, it is your job to keep these secrets under wraps. If any of them breathe out into the public consciousness, there is a very real chance of panic and chaos in the streets. President JFK made that mistake, and he paid the ultimate price for his actions."

Steven narrowed his eyes. "Are you threatening me?"

"Not me, personally." Agent Silver replied. "I am only a representative of a much greater force. As we speak, there is a secret war being waged across Earth. It is a silent war, one the media has been deliberately made blind to, covered up by innumerable powerful and ancient organizations. It is unfortunate that you and every other President had to assume office without knowing the full gravity of the situation you are undertaking, but past experiments have shown this is the only way to be sure."

"Be sure there are no leaks?" Steven asked, feeling a little unsettled.

"You're fast on the uptake. That will make this easier." Silver replied.

He paused.

"The American public, and the rest of humanity, are living under the assumption that you, the US President, are the leader of the free world. You are not. Put simply, you are the public face of an organization with roots far deeper what you can imagine."

Silver touched his chest. "My name is Agent Silver. That is not a code-name. It is my *actual* name. I was born and raised by the Illuminati, and trained to be one of its most formidable Agents. I am not the only one of my rank, and there are others like me."

"The Illuminati..." President Johannesburg said skeptically.

"That's right. I know you might find it crazy, but my job is to inform you of the Truths to which you are ignorant. I am here to answer all your questions, once I have completed my basic summary."

And so, Agent Silver began to speak. He opened up the briefcase he brought with him, and started pulling out folders, case files, pictures, and all sorts of thumbdrives containing audio and video recordings of things Steven became increasingly alarmed by.

"This is a picture of him." Silver said, holding out a photo for Steven to look at. "Satan the Devil. He operates out of New York City, using a shell corporation named Legion. You've probably heard of it. They run commercials on FOX News."

"You're fucking kidding me." Steven softly exclaimed. "Satan? The Devil?? Are you out of your mind? This is the most ludicrous horseshit I've ever heard in my life!"

Silver nodded. "Every single President says that."

"No, no, don't you just sit there and nod your head like some wise sage!" Steven shouted. "This is actual insanity! A worldwide effort to cover up the existence of demons, angels, monsters, and all kinds of other shit? A perpetual war dating back tens of thousands of years, right back to the start of human history? All that, and nobody knows about it?! It's fundamentally impossible for nobody to know about this!"

"Mmm. You're misunderstanding something." Silver said, pursing his lips. "People *do* know. You knew before I told you. Haven't you seen a movie with demons and angels in it? Read a book? Read the *Bible*? It's all out there. We keep the conspiracy in plain view. Through centuries of careful propagandizing, brainwashing, and manipulation of the masses, we've convinced people that demons, angels, and other 'mythical' figures are just that; figures of myth and legend. Demons sometimes walk in plain view nowadays and people think they're *cosplayers*. The conspiracy has been so successful that when people see something out of the ordinary, we don't even have to mind-wipe them. They just assume their brain screwed up for a moment, they shrug, and they forget what they saw."

He continued. "Sure, some people don't fall for the brainwashing. But we call them 'Truthers' and make them out to be crazies. Then when they start rabidly proclaiming that they *really* saw a demon walking around, their own friends and family ostracize them. It's all very complex, and yet beautifully simple in how the system functions."

Steven stared blankly at his desk. His face had become ashen and lost its color. His tired eyes looked utterly haggard. Every word Silver said struck him like a bullet. He looked like he would tip over if someone touched his shoulders too hard.

"Why... tell me all this?" Steven asked. "Are you telling me that all *this* is now my responsibility?"

Silver stayed quiet for a time. He allowed the silence to percolate, and for Steven's head to become clearer.

"No." Silver finally said. "This war is not your responsibility. Not exactly. If the people above you, the true rulers of humanity, say that the United States needs to engage in a military conflict, you must publicly comply with the order. You have no choice."

He continued. "What you are is the public face of humanity. A puppet, or perhaps a figurehead, if you prefer that term instead. Your job is to make the 'endless wars in the Middle East' more palatable for the voters. If necessary, you will take the fall when things go south, as they always inevitably do. This is not a war of extinction at present, but a war

for supremacy. Humanity is slowly making great gains and winning over our demonic enemies. We need to maintain morale while keeping the public in the dark about what is truly going on."

Steven grabbed at his hair. "Silver, I am a *Democrat*. I ran on ending the wars! I came into this office with good intentions, but now you're telling me that I'll have to lie to the people with a straight face? I have to make up excuses for why the war can't be stopped?"

"The war is unending." Silver replied smoothly. "Syria one day, Iraq another, maybe even Canada tomorrow. We're lucky the largest concentration of demons hide in the barren wastelands of the Middle East, but they blend in to human populations too. They secretly take hostages without the people around them even knowing. If we don't fight back, their numbers will climb, and the balance of power may tilt out of our favor."

Steven blinked. "Then- wait, does that mean all the atrocities of the past were the fault of the demons? Nazi Germany? Mao? Stalin?"

"Not all, no." Silver said quietly. "Humans are sometimes even more horrible to each other than we are to the demons, or vice-versa."

"But the angels are our allies, right?" Steven asked.

Silver slowly shook his head. "They 'ally' with us. But they are not our friends. The angels are, in many ways, even more frightening than the demons. Every day, tens, even hundreds of thousands of humans die. Their bodies perish, but their souls are 'saved' and taken to Heaven, where they are processed and revived in new bodies. Those humans become half-angels, entities known as Lazarites. They are made into soldiers that fight for the angels, and their numbers increase all the time."

"The angels are just as opportunistic as the demons." Silver explained. "The progenitor of the Illuminati, the very first human Hero, his name was Jepthath the Illuminator. He was deceived by the angels, and the power that should have passed down his bloodline instead became a spiritual entity that attached itself to random humans across history. Because of Raphael's deception, humanity was weakened, but we still persevered. We endured, we adapted, and we overcame our adversities."

Silver smiled, and in that smile, Steven Johannesburg saw something that chilled him to his core. It was a fervent look of devotion; the eyes of a religious zealot!

He wasn't some calm and collected sage. He was a madman who believed only in human supremacy! He concealed his true thoughts behind a calm façade, but in that moment, Steven fully saw through it.

Even so, there was nothing he could do to change the situation.

Steven considered calling people to escort Silver out of his office, to banish this new false 'truth' from his eyes, but the evidence was overwhelming. Silver wasn't some quack making things up who managed to sneak into the White House and play a prank on the unsuspecting President. He was a genuine representative of a human supremacy movement fighting to maintain total control of the Earth for millennia.

The President lowered his head and closed his eyes. He sank into thought, uncertain of what he should do.

Everything he believed about becoming the most powerful man in America had fallen apart in an afternoon. His life's work had become a complete joke. His 'agenda' meant nothing. Even if he managed to push forward his vision for America's future, he would only do so at the behest of humanity's true rulers... if they were *kind enough* to 'let him' do it.

"Let's... get back to the main topic." Steven said tiredly, lifting his head. "You've told me... all of this. So, what now?"

"Well, every day, our Metaphysical Response Units (MRUs) deal with countless demonic incidents, unbeknownst to you or the general public." Silver explained. "But practically the day you took office, something happened that none of our agents were expecting."

Silver tilted his head down slightly and gave Steven a knowing look out of the corner of his eye.

"A Hero was finally found, after decades of silence. Not just one, but two. Cat Mask and the Archseer. Humanity's greatest champion has returned, but there are two of them, now. A father and son. This changes the game completely. The demons were falling behind for the last several decades due to complacency. Humanity's armies are strong, but without a Hero to unite us, the demons stopped seeing us as a real threat. They thought they could play the long game and subsume our bases of power over time, but now they know the rules have changed."

Steven nodded. He wasn't an idiot. Now that he had carefully swallowed this complete reframing of the world and its working principles, he was slowly returning to his center of gravity. He was able to start mentally mapping out the way the demons would react based on his knowledge of how human leaders might.

"Demons are intelligent, right?" Steven asked. "They aren't mindless monsters? They have thoughts, feelings, desires like us?"

"That's right, Mister President." Silver answered. "They may have a hunger for human souls to empower themselves, but fundamentally the majority love food, sex, and wealth like you and me. That's why despite humanity not having a Hero, we were able to make big inroads in subduing them more peacefully in the past. We have many more cultural pieces that appeal to the demons, allowing us to pull some of them over to our side. Our efforts with the Hell of Isolation have borne especially sweet fruit."

"We can ally with the demons?" Steven asked. "That's an option?"

Silver grimaced. "The Illuminati... does not condone these actions. We detest them. There are other ancient organizations who foolishly believe that appeasing or befriending the other Sentients is a solid long-term plan, but my people fundamentally state these actions are pure folly."

Steven's eyes flashed. He suddenly realized the situation was not as Silver had presented it! Silver had made it seem as though the Illuminati ruled the world, but in actual fact, there were other ancient organizations.

That meant there were many different viewpoints. Competitors. Possible ways to make inroads with various powerful factions.

He finally saw a way out of the situation he thought he'd become trapped in! It wasn't that he had instantly been converted to a puppet, forced to serve the Illuminati, but that the Illuminati had reached him first to try and influence him to their side.

A sneer formed on Steven's lips. He realized he had almost been played.

"So... who are the *other* ancient organizations?" Steven asked, giving Silver a long, meaningful stare.

Silver's heart skipped a beat. He suddenly realized he had screwed up, and the cat was out of the bag.

Even so, his momentary jolt of surprise vanished as quickly as it came. His facial expression never changed.

"I know what you're thinking, Mister President. You think that you can push your agenda through if you get the support of the other ancient organizations. You think you can pit us against each other. But to us, you're only a man who will be in office for half a decade, or less than a decade at most. You're not the first President to harbor such thoughts."

Silver continued. "The other organizations are too many and numerous to list in their entirety. The Illuminati is, without a doubt, the most powerful one. But the Knights Templar, Majestic 12, Freemasons, and the Bilderberg Group are among a few of the most powerful ones. You're probably familiar with Bilderburg, because they are the newest organization created after World War II who scout out ambitious and promising talents like yourself to assume roles in government. Their military power is minimal, but their social influence is high."

Silver cocked his head.

"Let's get one thing out of the way. The Illuminati aren't only the strongest because of our mission statement and military backbone. We also have the full support and current leadership of both Heroes walking the Earth. We take orders from Cat Mask and the Archseer. None of the other organizations have the Heroic Mandate that we do. They will never be able to suppress us, so don't go thinking you can weaponize them to suppress our voice."

Steven's eyes darkened. "Yeah? And what's stopping me from taking all this public? Telling the people the Truths you've been suppressing?"

Silver gave him a look like he was an idiot. "If you want to try, go ahead. Nobody would believe you. They'll call any evidence you show CGI or AI or some other thing. Anyone who believes you will become a conspiracy theorist. If you somehow succeed, we'll send the Men in Black to wipe a few memories. Countless special interests rely on the status quo being maintained."

"Fine." Steven said, his tone sullen.

He leaned his head back and stared up at the ceiling.

"Just tell me what I'm doing then, since I have no autonomy."

Silver's voice softened. "Mister President, just because this office isn't what you expected, that doesn't mean you have no power. You are still responsible for countless small domestic and foreign matters the Illuminati and other organizations are uninterested in. The President might not be able to weaponize much of America's finest, but you are still instrumental in human-human relations. You maintain America's role as the world leader, and you preserve our global hegemony. So long as you don't do anything stupid, like randomly slapping tariffs on all our allies, or starting an unsanctioned war in the Middle East, or using the office to enrich yourself and your allies while the public looks on in horror, or making a modern-day Gestapo to hunt down US citizens you don't like, that will never change."

Steven raised an eyebrow. "That seems highly specific."

"Just covering my bases." Silver replied.

The Agent waved his hand flippantly. "You are still a powerful man whose name will go down in history. By contrast, nobody will ever know of the work I do in the background. Enjoy the benefits of office, work to make a difference through those supposed small and inconsequential things, and you can make a tangibly positive impact on millions of lives."

That helped Steven feel a bit better. He quietly realized Silver was an exceptionally talented manipulator. From the very beginning, he had held the entire conversation in the palm of his hand.

"So... humanity's two newest Heroes. When will I meet them?" Steven asked.

"Sooner rather than later." Silver answered. "I can't give an exact date. They're sure to come visit you after they deal with other matters. Just remember, Mister President. These are legitimate superhumans we're talking about. They are insanely powerful. They can shatter buildings with their fists, fly, teleport, dodge or even tank bullets with their bodies... so if you piss them off, there's nothing we can do to protect you. Be on your best behavior. They are the true rulers of humanity, and their word is God's word."

Steven shuddered. "I'll... keep that in mind."

Agent Silver stood up, and Steven subconsciously stood up as well, feeling a sense of inferiority when he looked at the man before him. The President shook Silver's hand, and Silver left the office afterward.

Steven sat back in his chair. He spun around and stared out the giant windows behind himself, feeling gloomier than he had in ages.

"Demons. Angels. Monsters. Even living legends... Heroes. What in the fuck is this world I live in?"

After a few long, long minutes, he turned around, leaned forward, and hesitantly tapped a button on his phone.

"Kelly. Cancel my itinerary for today. Something's come up. Yes, everything."

He hung up the phone, then sank back into his chair.

He needed time to think, and to come to terms with his new reality.

"This changes everything." Steven muttered to himself.

Part 659: AMBITION

January 27th, 2021. 9 AM. Boise National Forest, Idaho.

Hideki Hiro sat on the sofa inside his log cabin, surrounded by various animals. Cats, dogs, birds, lizards, all manner of animals sat on the couch with him or nearby. Some of them sat on the fireplace mantle, some clung to shelves on the walls, and plenty simply sat or lay on the floor.

On the old-timey television television in front of the couch, Harold Whittaker sat in his rocking chair like he always did, but this time he was sitting motionless while directing a piercing stare at Hideki.

"Eh? Wassat?" Harold asked, leaning forward and cupping a hand to his ear. "I didn't quite make it out!"

"Don't play old and deaf with me, gramps." Hideki said with a chuckle. "Your senses are sharper than many demons. You heard me rightly. Jason is putting the finishing touches on a hidden world. Says it'll be a really cool secret base or something."

Harold's glossy-eyed look of foolishness slipped away. He leaned back in his chair and flippantly waved a hand at Hideki. "Bah. I'm too old for all that crap. So long as my friends can live good lives, I'm happy."

His friends, naturally, were all the animals living around the log cabin; those he had uplifted either deliberately or unwittingly for the last fifty-plus years. In total, there were about two hundred of them, but this number was deceptively small, as many more had already migrated out into the woods of Idaho, and further beyond...

"CAWWW! HAPPINESS IS BULLSHIT! CAWWW!" The loudmouthed crow in the room shouted.

"Do any of you want to come with me?" Hideki asked, smiling at the animals around him. "Jason will show up here in a minute to take me to his new land."

Most of the animals performed the equivalent of a shrug. The crow especially seemed uninterested.

"I will go." A regal-looking parakeet with bright blue feathers and a red head eventually said in a tone that was very un-parakeet-like. He puffed out his chest and

grandiosely swept his gaze around the room. "I should very much like to see what this new Holy Land looks like."

"STUPID IDIOT!" The Crow squawked. "BORING LAND! MUCH NICER HERE! NO STINKING HUMANS BOTHERING YOU! CAWWW!"

"Jeffery, be nice." Hideki lightly admonished the crow. "Sir Marcus, if you want to come along, I can have Jason bring you. Anyone else?"

Sir Marcus, the parakeet, nodded his bright red head and flaw over to Hideki's shoulder, landing smoothly and without error. "I suggest everyone else stay here. I will return post-haste and inform you all of the sights I've witnessed."

The other animals nodded. They weren't too interested in leaving the log cabin, not being adventurous types.

Shortly after, a figure flickered inside the room, revealing himself to be Jason Hiro. He looked the same as ever, and nothing appeared different from the last time anyone had seen him... at least not on the surface.

"Dad." Jason said, nodding to Hideki. "And all the rest of you. Aevum is finally ready for visitors. Are you?"

"It's just going to be me and Sir Marcus." Hideki said, gesturing with his thumb at the pretty blue parakeet on his shoulder. "The others want to wait and hear from him later before they decide to visit or not."

Jason smiled. "That'll do. Let's go then. **Return!**"

The second the Word of Power left Jason's mouth, he and his father vanished from the log cabin, and the world around them instantly changed.

Hideki swayed on his feet. He felt slightly dizzy for a moment, but the feeling quickly passed. He stood tall and looked around the room he had just appeared inside.

It was some sort of white-tiled medical facility, complete with simplistic-looking bipedal robots that stood at attention and assessed the new arrivals with blank eyes. These robots appeared relatively human, except for the shiny and smooth metal plating on their bodies. Their strangely thin metal 'fingers' looked like one-sided tweezers with little gripping force.

The room itself had several medical beds along the side walls, as well as monitoring stations and other such equipment. Jason noticed the momentary confusion on Hideki's

face and quickly explained.

"This is the Arrival Area." Jason explained. "Pending a better name, I guess. Because Aevum exists in a higher dimension where time moves at 365 times reality's speed, there's a real chance someone transitioning between temporal dimensions will have a medical complication. Thus, we send them here to ensure robodocs can take care of them in case they collapse. Are you feeling alright, dad?"

Hideki took a moment to assess his body. "I'm fine. How about you, Sir Marcus?"

The parakeet appeared unfazed. "I am feeling most excellent! Thank you for asking, Hideki."

Jason glanced at the parakeet. "You seem like a bright fellow."

"Thank you for the compliment!" Marcus chirped. "I do not know if I would refer to myself as 'bright' but I do have a PhD in physics! I even wrote a small dissertation on spatial folding!"

Seeing the confusion on Jason's face, Hideki butted in. "Marcus took online classes. Obviously he couldn't have attended in person."

Jason glanced at the bird's feet, seemingly putting two and two together. Apparently, he must have hopped around on a keyboard to type out his dissertation. That was... a novel way of doing things. Jason didn't think he had it in him to replicate such a feat, certainly not by typing with his toes.

These days, he could easily write a high level dissertation, but he had to admit that was only due to his artificial brain enhancements. Without them, he was not much smarter than any baseline human... probably *dumber*, if he was being especially hard on himself.

"Well, a few hundred years of life must have given me at least a *small* amount of wisdom." Jason muttered beneath his breath.

"What was that?" Marcus asked.

"Oh, nothing. Let's go." Jason answered.

In truth, Jason was no longer as foolish as during his youth. Sure, he screwed up and caused his wife to die, and Tarus II fell as well, but that was more due to the sudden and unexpected Volgrim sneak attack. Had they not betrayed him, he would have continued to amass power and slowly draw the galaxy into the palm of his hand.

He silently vowed to never fall for such a deception ever again.

The Arrival Area was located on the southern outskirts of Argent, within the Great Barrier, but far enough from the center of Aevum that if an enemy were to arrive inside they wouldn't immediately be able to wreck the most important components of Aevum.

As Jason, his father, and the bird perched on Hideki's shoulder emerged from the underground chamber and stepped into Argent's city limits, Hideki couldn't help but pause, gape in awe, and look around his surroundings with widened eyes.

"No cheating, dad." Jason said to Hideki with a smirk. "Don't you dare rewind and pretend not to be amazed."

"I... would never..." Hideki murmured, seemingly in a trance.

The pitch-black sky above, lacking in starlight, nonetheless glowed due to the presence of a giant false star. This star was actually not large by any means, and was simply close enough to Aevum's planetary surface that its small size gave it the perfect falsified appearance of a yellow M-class star, like Earth's Sol.

Birds chirped in the air. Many cute critters crawled around Argent's inner city limits. Unlike the land outside Argent, these critters were treated purely as decoration and groundskeepers, their population managed by a system Jason had yet to show off to anyone else. Their primary purpose was to chew on any greenery that grew too tall, but without natural predators inside of Argent, they might explode in number and overwhelm the inner city's natural food reserves.

Twelve towering spires rose from the ground and twisted into the sky. Each sent a beam of energy into the Nexus Tower, and each beam was colored differently. Even someone totally unversed in magic could tell at a glance that these towers were based on various elements. Water, fire, earth, air, light, dark, magnetism, electricity, and even a few other strange and exotic ones Hideki could not identify at a glance. These towers surrounded the Nexus but were placed quite a distance away from the central tower, seemingly keeping them from interfering with one another.

Hideki's gaze happened to fall toward the ground. He spotted glowing lines of energy that pulsed beneath his feet, as if the very planet of Aevum itself were a living, breathing entity. These were the Leylines of magic that supported several auxiliary functions of Aevum, but Hideki simply had no way of comprehending what it all tied into. Not yet, at least, as Jason had explained nothing.

In addition to the false sun in the sky, there were also a number of curious black diamond-shaped objects floating high in the air above. Each one was as big as several city buses stacked together, and there appeared to be twelve of them, the same number as the elemental towers. They hovered directly above the towers, but at a high elevation; their purpose unknown.

"Alright..." Hideki said, after a long minute of taking the sights in. "I'll admit it. I'm utterly confused, but equally impressed."

He gave his son an inscrutable look, as if he couldn't quite believe the changes Jason had undergone. Was this really the dumb little dipshit who, in every other previous life incarnation, had never amounted to anything and had ended up completely wasting his powers? The Jason before him now had just created something so far out the realm of Hideki's expectations that, frankly, he couldn't begin to guess at what Aevum's holistic purpose was. Jason hadn't told him much of anything before he left Earth to build this place!

Time was of the essence, of course. Hideki certainly didn't blame his son. The sooner Aevum was constructed, the sooner Jason could put its time dilation to use and start rapidly advancing his future goals.

"Let's go on a tour." Jason said with a smile.

He uttered a few Words of Power, and a flying boat manifested on the ground a short distance away. It completely resembled an ordinary rowboat, but when Hideki and his son stepped inside, it lifted into the air and began to fly into the sky.

As they flew upward, Hideki could finally get an aerial view of the city. His eyes nearly popped out of his head! The Leylines he'd noticed on the ground were nothing compared to what was visible from above! There were hundreds, thousands, even hundreds of thousands of Leylines stretching across every meter of Argent's inner city limits. The magical energy traveling within them pulsed regularly, with a rhythm not dissimilar to a beating heart. The more Hideki observed them, the more they seemed to resemble blood vessels.

"Aevum is a living entity." Jason began to explain. "Currently, it is non-sentient. It is a 'miniature' moon-sized celestial object less than 100 kilometers in diameter that operates purely based on pre-programmed magical software. Every day, it slowly grows in size,

causing minor planetquakes. These are not a big issue though, as I used magic to localize those quakes outside of Argent in the Proving Grounds."

Hideki was tongue-tied. He had, naturally, studied countless scientific and magical texts across his long and storied life, but nothing had prepared him for the words his son was speaking.

Sir Marcus, on the other hand, was less star-struck. The little parakeet took this shocking new reality in stride!

"Most impressive!" Marcus chirped. "I can easily see that everything in Aevum is well-thought out; all part of a centralized concept. Every individual component works together in harmony."

"That's right." Jason said, directing an appreciative gaze at the funny bird. "It all has a purpose. Take for example the Nexus Tower; the heart of Aevum."

He gestured toward the massive spire in the center of Argent.

"This tower has so much solar and magical energy flowing through it, it would knock your socks off. At present, I have only managed to siphon the energy of twelve stars from outside Aevum's voidspace, but due to my incredible advancements in efficient engineering, these stars are ten times more valuable than the stars I siphoned energy from back when I made Chrona! If I could only tap into 1% of a star's energy before, I can siphon 10% now! Truly an order of magnitude in efficiency!"

Jason gestured toward several surprisingly barren areas inside the city where nothing had been built yet.

"Aevum is still incomplete. I've only worked on it for about a year, but there's plenty more to do. Over there, south of the Nexus, at the site of the Life Tower, I plan to create the 'Aegis Womb'. This might sound strange, but I had a burst of inspiration, and I realized I could harness the power of Life Energy to grow random, mutated artifacts. I won't be able to control their growth much if at all, but because they will be mostly hands-off, they will likely grow quite formidable over time!"

He pointed to the east. "And over there in that spot, next to the Gravitic Tower, I'll build The Threshold. That's where I'll be constructing massive subdimensions capable of shrinking and distorting the mass of objects so I can build up a stockpile of weapons, armor, vehicles, and other implements."

He pointed to the west. "The Electric Tower is also quite interesting. That's where I'll be building the Simulacrum Hub, which will connect to the twelve floating pylons in the sky. You see those black diamond-shaped things way up there? Those are where people will be able to enter and train inside of a virtual environment. I actually had the idea based on the Queen Network, but this implementation is much more advanced!"

"The Queen Network?" Hideki asked.

"Ah, it's a virtual simulation where people can gain practical fighting experience without fear of dying. However, the Simulacrum is even better! I borrowed Mildred's idea of that Titan-based Mindcore, the *RealitySim*, and took it to the next level. Since I can't fit two MindCores in my head, why not build a much bigger version of one so I can access it as needed?!"

"You can do that?" Hideki asked in surprise. "Won't that be dangerous? Couldn't it hurt you if you connected to another MindCore? That's what Mildred said after all..."

"Correct." Jason answered. "But don't worry, dad. The Simulacrum won't *actually* be a MindCore. It will simply be a highly advanced virtual environment capable of hooking up to my brain and the brains of other people. In this way, I can obtain the benefits of a RealitySim MindCore without having to pay the price!"

Jason paused, then looked at his father meaningfully.

"Not just me. You as well. Daisy. Everyone..."

Hideki frowned. He noticed the changed look on his son's face.

"Jason? What's this all about? There's something you're not telling me."

The flying boat came to a stop in midair. Jason turned to look out at Argent, staring at some small Finch-like birds flying through the air and chirping at one another.

A desolate look of sadness momentarily passed across his face before disappearing.

"I've always had it wrong." Jason said slowly. "From the very beginning."

"Had what wrong?" Hideki carefully asked.

"My purpose. My role in... all 'this.' The answer to the question about my life's purpose." Jason said, his tone melancholic. "I was so arrogant in my youth. I might not have seemed like it, always acting humble and trying to downplay my importance, but the truth is... I enjoyed having humanity rely on me. It was selfish. It was egotistical."

Jason looked his father in the eyes.

"When I met you and learned your story, it finally clicked. You put in the work. You spilled blood, sweat, and tears to put humanity on as perfect of a future trajectory as possible. You min-maxed every aspect of reality that you could affect until, eventually, you put me in position to save humanity 100,000 years in the future. If it wasn't for you, I would have died a nobody. All my accomplishments came from you."

Jason lowered his eyes. He stared at the ground in a manner most somber.

"I'm not humanity's Hero. I am not its savior. I am not the protagonist who should singlehandedly save everyone all with my own strength. And looking back, it's so obvious that this has always been the case; only my ego prevented me from seeing."

"My power is Wordsmithing. Put succinctly, I am a 'Creator'. I can enhance my body, enhance my fighting capabilities, and make myself fairly formidable... but I am the ultimate Generalist. Spending all my time trying to turn myself into a one-man-army is a waste! It's stupid, inefficient, and only something a blind fool would do."

Jason lifted his head and gestured broadly to Aevum.

"This. All of this. It's not for me. It's for the future warriors of humanity. It's for you, Daisy, and everyone else who will follow in your footsteps. I built Aevum for one purpose; to create an unstoppable human army that can sweep across the galaxy, overturn all the rules, and become invincible among their peers."

Hideki sucked in a small breath. "That's your plan? That's Aevum's central focus? Making *other* humans powerful instead of yourself?"

"One hundred percent." Jason said with a wry smile. "Every minute I'm out there, in Realspace, fighting demons, I am wasting the gift the Creator gave me. I can fight, but I'm not a fighter. I can save people, but I'm not a savior. My job is to uplift others, to empower them, and make them the Heroes of their own story."

"The Simulacrum will allow people to train their powers, no matter what element they specialize in, and wield them with the prowess of a true powerhouse."

"The Aegis Womb will, in time, create various somewhat random artifacts, some of which will potentially end up in the hands of the perfect wielder. It will take time, but the results will speak for themselves."

"Outside Argent's Great Barrier, the Proving Grounds will slowly create more and more powerful monstrous beasts to allow our people to become adept at hunting fearsome live prey."

"Axis Mundi, The Infinite Mountain, will spew forth Genesis Ichor to greatly speed up the evolution of creatures that drink from it. Many will die, but some will evolve, rise up, and become apex exobeasts! Their bodies will not just make for fine trophies to those that hunt them down, but will also be usable in creating new Exotic materials to then turn into new Artifacts!"

"This is what Aevum is." Jason said, looking up at the Nexus Tower with stars in his eyes. "It is the future holy land of humanity! A place where the most deserving of humans can come to break past their limits! To ascend to godhood! To become capable of stepping on the heads of aliens and other Sentients who once thought themselves our betters!"

Jason stood up in the boat and raised his fist to the sky.

"If I must take a backseat so that others may rise to save humanity, then so be it! From now on, my only goal is to become the best Wordsmith possible; to reach the absolute apex of what my abilities can achieve! To that end, I will set aside my ego, my vanity, and my desire to be the focal point of humanity's future. I will allow myself to fade away into time, and for people to slowly forget me, so long as it results in my enemies failing to understand how important my work behind the scenes truly is!"

As Hideki looked up at the fire in his son's eyes, he couldn't help but become infected with the strange, almost religious fervor flowing from his soul.

Jason had finally set aside his self-loathing and doubt in order to become a better version of himself.

Yes, he had failed his daughter in the past. He had failed his wife. He had failed his friends and family.

But a true man could never allow these failures to define him! So long as Jason drew breath, there was always hope for redemption. There was always a way to reignite the fire that once lay dormant!

Jason slowly lowered his fist. He closed his eyes for a moment and released a long, deep sigh.

Then he opened his eyes and gazed into his father's soul.

"The real work begins now, dad. From now on, you will become humanity's most feared Hero. I will make you into a monster the Volgrim avoid, the demons skulk in the shadows when you draw near, and the angels never *dare* to double-cross."

"Not just you." Jason said softly. "But also Daisy, and all the other humans who will soon come to rely on me."

Hideki stood up. He gently clasped his son's shoulders and smiled.

"Tell me what you need me to do, kid. I'm yours to command."

Part 660: Hideki's Evolution

January 27th, 2021. Argent City, Aevum.

Jason and his father, as well as Sir Marcus, flew through the air on the magical rowboat Jason had created with his Wordsmithing. As they flew, Jason began to explain his broad plans.

"I can't be the face of humanity." Jason said. "So it has to be you, dad. You've lived longer than any Volgrim, even Unarin, and you've lived longer than all but the most ancient of beings, such as Archangel Raphael. You likely have a lot of wisdom, and probably a good amount of fighting experience. Am I correct in my assumptions?"

Hideki sat inside the rowboat as it flew over one of the twelve elemental spires. He massaged his chin while gazing at the incredible world his son had created, a world that was still in heavy development.

"I wouldn't call myself a master of combat, but there's probably several millions of years of training in there. Over time, older skills tend to become rusty. I'm more proficient with firearms than I am hand-to-hand combat these days, but even that has some... quirks."

"It's more than me, and that's all that matters." Jason said, dismissing his father's concerns. "My mind has lived for about 300 years. I did quite a bit of training in Chrona, but mostly I focused my efforts on learning how to wield a bo staff. With other weapons, I only have a superficial level of fighting capability. When I say that you would stomp me into the dirt in a show of weaponry skill, I'm not being humble. It's simply the truth."

Jason continued. "Right now, you are mostly just an ordinary human. During our fight against the Demon Emperors, I gave both of us a powerful defensive boost, but Ose still wiped the floor with us and she was only a Baron. Now that she's an Emperor, I need to go even further and make you unstoppable. With your ability to slow your perception of time, you might be the only one capable of beating her... short of me coming up with a way to assassinate her in secret. That isn't outside the realm of possibility, so I'll keep working on it."

Jason spoke a Word of Power, then held up his hand to conjure a holographic image of his father's body, but with a wireframe model over top of it.

"Aside from the MindCore given shape by Archangel Camael, taken from a melted-down Solomon's Crown, your body has no innate natural abilities. You can't summon lightning, throw fireballs, manipulate water, or do anything else like that. Your brainpower is excellent, and your ability to reduce the speed of time and rewind it during crises are your sole powers. This means your limits are not as high as any chosen Demon Emperor, but you also don't have any major weaknesses you need to worry about. If I can holistically improve your bodily potential, you could become a real terror to the demons, and eventually, the Volgrim."

Jason waved his hand, causing the holographic image to split into three forms.

"There are three main body development paths you can take, dad. It's not possible for me to max out your 'stats' across the board, but I can definitely work some magic on you to make you formidable. Look at this center hologram. This represents the 'you' of now."

Jason nodded his head. A series of stats appeared above the middle Hideki Hologram's head.

[BASELINE HUMAN]

HEALTH: 100

MANA: 100

STRENGTH: 10

DEXTERITY: 10

ENDURANCE: 10

CONSTITUTION: 10

INTELLIGENCE: 10

WISDOM: 10

CHARISMA: 10

"These are currently the baseline for any average human." Jason explained. "Think of them like IQ scores. A single point up or down is huge, with 10 being the baseline for an average Sentient, 20 being the cap for mortal beings, including entities like Demon

Emperors, while 0 means no potential or ability whatsoever. Here's what your stats look like now."

The numbers shifted.

[HIDEKI HIRO]

HEALTH: 100

MANA: 0

STRENGTH: 12

DEXTERITY: 13

ENDURANCE: 13

CONSTITUTION: 12

INTELLIGENCE: 18

WISDOM: 19

CHARISMA: 20

Hideki nodded along, mostly getting the gist of what Jason was saying. "So right now, due to my age and experience, as well as the MindCore made from Solomon's Crown, I'm an intelligence specialist?"

"That's right." Jason said. "But unlike magical entities such as demons and angels, you don't actually have any magical powers. Your time slowdown and stopping powers, as well as rewinding; those don't actually tire you out, right?"

Hideki shook his head. "I can use my powers as much as I want. I can slow down time and think in hyperspeed for days or months if I want. It's terribly boring though, so I don't usually do that."

"This is why your 'mana' is represented as zero." Jason explained. As for your other stats, they're all either average or above average, especially compared to baseline humans. You work out a lot and keep yourself in tip-top shape, but compared to your enemies, it's not much to speak of."

"That sounds about right." Hideki affirmed. "So what next?"

With a blink of his eyes, Jason adjusted the three holograms to change all of their stats at once. Each one reflected a potential 'new' version of Hideki, and all of them were far superior to the Hideki of now.

[HIDEKI HIRO - PSYKER]

HEALTH: 100

MANA: 500

STRENGTH: 11

DEXTERITY: 12

ENDURANCE: 16

CONSTITUTION: 16

INTELLIGENCE: 20

WISDOM: 20

CHARISMA: 20

"This one represents your latent potential tuned to the extreme." Jason explained. "I can create special and unique artifacts *just* for you, dad. With your ability to slow time, you'll be able to unleash their effects on enemies whenever they least expect them. I will fine tune your body so you become an archmage the demons fear."

After explaining the leftmost hologram's changes, Jason then gestured to the newly upgraded one in the middle.

[HIDEKI HIRO - CHAMPION]

HEALTH: 250

MANA: 150

STRENGTH: 17

DEXTERITY: 15

ENDURANCE: 17

CONSTITUTION: 17

INTELLIGENCE: 18

WISDOM: 18

CHARISMA: 18

"This one represents your future potential by merely increasing all of your stats to a pretty high, but not godly high, level." Jason explained. "You'll be able to stomp most powerful foes into meat paste, but you will become a powerful generalist instead of a specialist. In terms of life preservation, this development track means a very high defense and offense potential, especially if you push your body to its limits. But if you go up against Bael, he'll be tougher than you, while Ose will be faster, and Belial will hit harder. You have to use your strengths to beat their weaknesses."

Hideki appeared intrigued. "How will you accomplish the strengthening? Just by using your power to make my body stronger?"

"Actually, I'm not going to use Wordsmithing directly on you." Jason countered. "Too many drawbacks and limitations. Instead, I'll be implanting various technological and magical devices into your body, bones, and muscles. These will increase your 'stats' in various ways, but also give you new and powerful abilities."

Jason gestured toward the third hologram with his head. "But before you make a decision, check out this development track."

[HIDEKI HIRO - HUMANITY'S BULWARK]

HEALTH: 500

MANA: 0

STRENGTH: 19

DEXTERITY: 18

ENDURANCE: 20

CONSTITUTION: 20

INTELLIGENCE: 17

WISDOM: 18

CHARISMA: 18

"This one is the real deal." Jason explained. "You will continue exactly as you are, with no magical abilities, but you will be insanely powerful. If you tussle with Bael, you'll win every time. Ose won't even be able to scratch you. In terms of sheer power, this one might lack tricks, but you will become overwhelmingly unbeatable. I also like this one because, as you are my father, it makes you very hard to kill."

Jason's eyes flickered for a moment. "I've lost too many of the people I love. I'll admit, I'm biased, but... I don't want to put your life at risk, dad. I think you should consider the Bulwark option."

Hideki did not immediately answer. The rowboat hovered in the air for a long time, and the bird on his shoulder was the one to break the silence.

"I do not believe the Bulwark option is the correct choice." Sir Marcus said, in his typically polite and refined style. "Hideki does not fear death, because his power already prevents him from dying. In any moment when a fatal attack would envelop him, time freezes to a stop. This ensures he has always been able to save his life by rewinding to a safe point in the past. Thus, the high defenses are made redundant."

Jason frowned. "Maybe so, but being able to eat one of Bael's punches without breaking a sweat is still a big deal."

"In the future, there will be other humans who can perform such feats." Marcus said, while closing his eyes and lowering his beak. "Thus, I think this is the worst option. It does not utilize Hideki's unique strengths, but instead makes him more generic. There are plenty of brutes and strongmen. He is not one of them."

Hideki nodded. "Yeah, and going along with that, the Champion 'build' also doesn't appeal to me. It mainly feels like the Bulwark, but worse. If my choices are only these three, then Psyker is absolutely the option I choose."

Jason raised his eyebrows in surprise. "I don't disagree that it's a good choice, but.. are you sure?"

"Son, generalists are great, don't get me wrong." Hideki explained. "But I suspect you're going to have *plenty* of strong men and women fighting for you soon enough,

especially given your plans for Aevum. The Psyker option seems compelling because it adds to my toolkit and gives me a lot of options during battle. What kind of powers were you planning for me to wield?"

Jason chewed his lower lip. "Well, I was thinking first of some basic elemental abilities, like allowing you to fire lightning out of your hands, or fireballs, or other stuff. But also, if I can find a way to leverage your innate control of time, I might be able to let you 'freeze' people in a stasis bubble, or maybe rewind them at the molecular level, giving you the ability to heal certain injuries and illnesses."

"You see?!" Hideki snapped. "That sounds badass! Way more compelling than just becoming some burly guy who can punch hard and run fast! The more powers I have in my arsenal, the more options I can deploy in any given situation. Let's go with the Psyker option, kid."

Jason hesitated for a moment longer, but sensing his father's excitement, he shrugged and went with it.

"Alright, if you say so. There's a lot of different ways I can outfit you, dad." Jason said. "To start, we could allow you to cast spells with a long prep time that hit hard, or we could focus on giving you weaker instant-attack abilities. We could also give you one-time-use powers that hit between the former two in terms of damage output, but need to recharge over a long period of time before you use them again. Think like powerful abilities with a cooldown in a video game."

"Why are you describing everything with video game jargon anyway?" Hideki asked.

"Because it's simpler this way." Jason explained. "Using 'stats' makes it easier for me to explain the pros and cons of each choice. Look, imagine something like this..."

Jason summoned a few different illustrative videos of a wireframe-man casting spells.

On the left one, he chanted a spell for ten long seconds before firing a massive blast of lightning that tore apart the near side of a mountain.

On the middle one, he instantly case a notably weaker version of the spell, but he could only cast it once before switching to a giant fireball.

On the right one, he cast an even weaker bolt of lightning, but he shot multiple of them out one after another, rapid fire, while his MP meter depleted with each shot.

"Of these choices?" Hideki asked. "It's the middle one. For sure. I can use my rewinding ability to take out enemies at critical moments when their guards are down. I need a strong, instant, single-shot attack to one-tap them. A long chanting time eliminates the element of surprise, and a bunch of weak attacks are only suitable for battles of attrition. I've always won my fights by taking out my enemies in a single salvo, so this is my ideal setup."

Jason pondered his father's words. "So you want to become a magic focused Hero with an arsenal of one-time-use powers that hit like firetrucks. I can respect that. In fact, I might have a way to optimize purely for this style of fighting. I'll build an internal Mana Engine inside your body and have it supply the power needed for each spell. The spells themselves will consist of marble sized Mana Beads filled with enough energy to unleash the spell one time. After that, they will pull over a long period of time from your Mana Engine to recharge themselves. Even if you exhaust every Mana Bead at once, I can just swap them out if you travel back to Aevum, or you can wait a few days or a month and all of them will recharge."

"I have a suggestion!" Sir Marcus chirped. "Allow Hideki to recharge the spells in the order he deems most fitting. If he expends all of them, he should be able to focus energy into the most important ones, all so that if he ends up in another battle, he can still have some backup options left over!"

"I'll see if I can integrate that feature." Jason vowed. "We'll hash out the details later. For now, we can get back to business with Aevum."

With Hideki's future body enhancements decided, Jason changed topics resolutely.

The rowboat swooped down toward the center of Aevum, causing the Nexus Tower to loom above the trio.

"The Nexus channels the energy of stars from Realspace into Aevum." Sir Marcus said. "That much I understand. But I noticed earlier you said there were twelve Elemental Towers, and that you had linked to twelve stars. Does this mean that stars contain their own elemental affinities?"

"No, no, nothing like that." Jason said to the parakeet. "I made the towers first, then I powered them by drawing in the energy of twelve solar masses. However, I have a long way to go before I fully saturate each of the pylons. I would say that right now, at most, the Elemental Towers are operating at around 2% efficiency. I'll need to slowly draw in

the power of hundreds, maybe even thousands more stars before these twelve starting towers reach 100% saturation."

"That certainly seems like a lot of energy waste..." Marcus said hesitantly.

"I'm still working on the schematics." Jason explained. "My MindCore is great at designing things, but it can't work miracles. I still have to do the research and development; I can just do it way faster than even a dedicated team of genius humans. Over time, I'll upgrade the towers and improve their efficiency."

Jason's magical rowboat floated to the base of the Nexus. There, he gestured toward an opening at the bottom that was so pitch-black it swallowed all the light around it.

"Dad, you can only freeze time when your life is in peril, but that changes now. This is The Stillness. It's one of the most important components of Aevum."

"I... assume it has to do with freezing time." Hideki said, looking his son square in the eye as if he's just said the funniest thing possible. "But it also looks pretty dark and super evil. Don't tell me we're actually going *in* there?"

"We are. And don't worry, it's a little scary, but definitely not evil." Jason explained, as he led his father and Sir Marcus toward the ominous-looking pitch black entryway into the unknown. "The Stillness allows you to remain in suspended temporal animation for as long as you can handle it. From the perspective of the outside world, you would step inside and immediately step back out, but for you, hours or maybe even days would have passed."

"Are you planning to spend a lot of time in there?" Hideki asked. "If you can just instantly design thousands of new weapons, that would really improve the human war effort."

"Like I said." Jason repeated carefully. "It all depends on how long you can 'handle' being inside."

He stepped through the door while taking care to remain in physical contact with his father. A split-second later, the sounds of Aevum vanished, and an eerie, absolute silence swallowed the trio.

Inside the Stillness, there was a small bedroom. It had a bed, a table, and two chairs. There was nothing else inside, and the room was only illuminated by a pair of glowing purple stones that gave everything a sickly hue.

"Ultraviolet stones." Jason explained. "The Stillness is based off the principles of a black hole. Ordinary light is hard to discern, and only ultraviolet light serves to give enough illumination for us to see."

Jason's voice sounded hollow. It was as if the walls were swallowing his words, creating an empty vacuum of sound inside the room. Hideki and Marcus almost felt as if they were deep under the ocean, where all sounds were muffled by an invisible pressure pressing on their brains.

Hideki opened his mouth several times and tried to yawn and pop his ears, but the uncomfortable sensation never quite seemed to go away.

"Is this place... safe?" Hideki eventually asked, his voice sounding weirdly distant to him when he spoke.

"Unfortunately, I couldn't make a completely stable temporal sanctum." Jason said regretfully. "I've spent a few days here... with breaks in between. Usually, I can only manage to stay here for around twelve or so hours before I feel like my head is going to explode. I always left before things got too heavy, but... it definitely feels a little dangerous."

"I assume you would need to stay away from The Stillness for a period of time before you can re-enter." Marcus chimed in, his voice much hollower-sounding than before. "The pressure in here is almost certainly caused by heavy gravitational energy leaking past whatever barrier you used to contain it. I imagine compressing time to a standstill is... not something simple to accomplish."

"Not simple at all." Jason said with a nod.

He sat on the bed, and his father sat on one of the chairs. They remained quiet for a few minutes, while Hideki tried to adjust to The Stillness.

But eventually, he shook his head.

"This place ain't for me, son. I don't need lots of time to think about things. Solomon's Crown already speeds up my cognitive function, and I can always slow down time even further if I really need to take a beat. Even if rewinding has become a major pain in the ass, I can do that too. This place is just not for me."

"I thought it might not be." Jason said, slightly disappointed. "But hey! As long as you take some aspirin, you can sleep for twelve hours here and then walk out, a second having

passed in reality. That's one of the big reasons I made The Stillness; to give myself a way to instantly recover my mental energy in an emergency. That way, a situation like what happened when I fought Hope wouldn't occur again."

Jason shook his head, giving up on the idea of introducing other people to The Stillness. It really only benefited him, at least for now.

He and the other two stepped back out into Aevum, and the feeling of an anvil disappearing from the back of their brains made them feel a lot better. It was not pleasant inside there, but it might be a necessary pain worth suffering in certain situations, so Jason wasn't about to destroy it.

"So you're going to be staying in Aevum for the foreseeable future, then?" Hideki asked, turning to face his son.

"Yes." Jason answered slowly. "But... I might need to head out once or twice. Even though I need to dedicate time and energy to saving and uplifting humanity, there are still some matters that I absolutely have to take care of."

"Like what?" Hideki asked.

Jason smiled at his father. "One of those matters involves a very large, very powerful Cube. An ancient artifact nobody in this galaxy knows about."

He looked away, and his smile faded.

"The other important matter... well, it's a personal problem. I'll deal with it next, after I've spent a couple more realspace-days inside Aevum. Once I've finished the major building steps, I'll bring you back and introduce you to your newly upgraded body, as well as the Proving Grounds outside Argent. That's where a lot of the *truly* interesting stuff is going to happen."

"Keep me appraised." Hideki said, slapping his son's shoulder with a warm smile on his face. "I have full faith in you, son. I don't know what the hell you went through in the future, but it really shaped you into a formidable man. Those demons and Volgrim have no idea what's coming."

Jason smirked.

"No. *They don't.*"

Part 661: Blacksite 41

January 27th, 2021. Twenty kilometers northeast of London.

In a seemingly empty and barren field, a quad-copter hovered in the air. It was an advanced model with blades contained inside circular chambers to lower the volume and make it somewhat stealthy, but its striking appearance did make it stand out more to those who saw it. Luckily, its pilot had taken an especially long and roundabout path to delivers its passengers across the many barren fields lining the landscape of Great Britain, far from the main roads where cars might casually spot its flight path.

The helicopter slowly lowered toward the field below, and at an indeterminate point, it passed through a barrier of energy that revealed the field was not as lifeless as it seemed. A single small concrete structure, barely the size of a park bathroom, stood in the center of the dead, yellowed grass, and a pair of men stood out in front of it, looking up at the descending copter.

After a minute or two, the flying machine finally landed. Another minute passed before a hatch opened up, revealing stairs that lowered to the ground. A well dressed man flanked by two bodyguards wearing tactical gear and sunglasses stepped off the quad-copter and made their way across the field.

The man in the business suit was relatively ordinary looking. He wasn't particularly handsome, but he had a notable air of charisma hidden behind his eyes. He had pale blonde hair, and it was quite thin, likely because he combed it over a bald spot that stubbornly grew bigger and bigger every year. He had sworn many times that if it became any worse, he would definitely shave his head, but the *voters* wouldn't like seeing such a drastic change in his image. Or at least, that's the reason he gave himself to continually deny the slow and unstoppable advancement of age.

"Prime Minister Sheldon." One of the two men near the concrete structure said, as the politician walked toward them. "It's a pleasure to finally introduce you to our little operation."

This first man who spoke wore a plaid shirt and beige dress jeans. His large and clunky glasses, coupled with his slightly slouched posture, gave him the air of a middle manager.

Sheldon assessed his figure immediately and assessed he was not the Person of Interest he had come to meet. That must instead be the man beside him.

Sheldon held out his hand and warmly shook the man's hand. He knew how to smile and play the part of a caring official. He'd done it a million times.

"And you are?" Sheldon asked.

"Sorry, I should have led with that, sir." The man said, chuckling awkwardly. "I'm Oliver Ward, Senior of Personnel Management at Blacksite 41. This young man beside me is our leading scientist, Edward Greer."

The moment Noah Sheldon's eyes fell on Edward's face, he sensed an aura even more formidable than his own. The charming young man, perhaps twenty-eight years of age, was nearing the prime of his life. He had a full head of blonde hair, a smile that would stun supermodels, and he wore a well-fitting dress shirt and tie. Everything about the man screamed 'future superstar.' If he ran for political office, he would become someone truly great.

"Edward! So you're the man whose name has been reaching my ears of late!" Sheldon exclaimed, his eyes visibly brightening. He clapped his hand into Edward's palm and grinned enviously at the handsome fellow blinding him with his superior aura. "I can't believe a guy as good-looking as you has put so many of the U.K.'s greatest nerds to shame! Can't you let some of your lessers have a taste of the spotlight?"

"Oh, I can't take all the credit," Edward said with a shameful wink. "It is a 'team effort' after all. Many brilliant men and women have contributed, including my fiance. Come on inside. We have everything prepared."

The group of three men and two bodyguards walked over to the building, which only had one door. It opened to reveal a service elevator leading deep into the planet's depths.

After they shut the door, the elevator spun up and began lowering them down at a surprisingly brisk pace. Sheldon almost immediately opted to ignore Oliver, the middle manager, to focus on Edward, whose star was far too bright to allow lesser men to compete.

"So, tell me about what's going on down here." Sheldon said. "I glanced through a few reports, but the bureaucratic wording... it can be a bit dry!"

"Dry indeed. I'll do my best not to bore you!" Edward chirped. "Here at Blacksite 41, we are focused on researching a certain 'exotic recovered object' that was imported from the United States. This object stumped countless leading scientists in the USA, until a team of people, led by me, managed to pass a qualifying test designed to prove we were capable of unlocking its secrets."

Edward continued. "As such, this site is partially funded by the USA, but to maintain relations, we have made sure that half of the funding comes from our government here as well."

"Good, good. Can't be having the Yanks eat up all the good stuff." Sheldon replied. "And this recovered... object. What is it, exactly? I didn't find a single mention of it in the files I was given, only vague descriptions. That's why I came here; to assess whether funding this Blacksite is truly in our country's interests."

Edward's smile vanished. In its place, a much more solemn and serious expression followed.

"Prime Minister. Under no circumstances can our great nation afford to defund this site. The 'object' in question is of such an advanced origin that it poses a threat to the entire planet. If another country were to take control of the object, it would be a catastrophic loss for us."

Sheldon blinked. He looked at Edward's face with surprise... and a hint of wariness.

"You believe it is that important?"

"I would rather die than allow it to leave our custody." Edward replied, his solemness even more stark than before. "I believe... it is *alien* in origin."

The elevator stopped, revealing a short hallway leading into an underground warehouse with shock troopers wearing heavy armor of an advanced type Sheldon had never seen before. He blinked twice when he saw the first two men flanking both sides of the entry corridor, coldly assessing him as a potential threat. It didn't matter if he was the Prime Minister; he still registered as a potential hostile in their eyes, and they gripped their rifles tighter when he and the others approached.

Once Sheldon passed by and nothing happened, he felt an odd sense of relief. "Those men felt... intense."

"Security is extremely tight down here. You can't see it, but you're being scanned by numerous systems to assess whether or not you are... human." Edward said, flashing a quick gaze at the side of Sheldon's head. "At Blacksite 41, no security precaution is too extreme. A single leak could bring all manner of hostiles upon us."

Before Edward could say anything else, the glasses-wearing man, Oliver, suddenly intervened.

"Ah, Prime Minister, have you been debriefed on the existence of... Red Sentients?"

Bewildered, Sheldon looked at the man with confusion written all over his face. "I'm sorry. Red Sentients? Is that code for something?"

Oliver paused his walking, then glanced at Edward. "Doctor, make sure you keep this meeting focused only on official matters, as he is not in the know."

Edward looked at the Prime Minister with a hint of pity. It seemed that even the leader of the country was on a need-to-know basis when it came to the existence of demonkind and other supernatural entities. That was a shame.

"Of course." Edward said. "Apologies, Prime Minister, but regarding this matter... I can't risk a court martial. Not even for your sake. If knowledge of the Red Sentients ever arrives on your desk, it will represent an unfortunate day for our country."

Sheldon raised an eyebrow. "Is this some top-secret matter?"

"I'm not at liberty to say." Edward replied apologetically.

"Alright. I'll speak to my aides later, see if I can find out from them..." Sheldon said, his tone uncertain.

As they continued, they passed by many isolated rooms with frosted glass windows that mostly hid the interior from the view of outside observers. Some of them, however, had men and women standing outside while wearing large goggles, watching whatever was happening inside. A few of the rooms even emitted bright lights, as if some sort of weapon testing was going on inside.

"We're almost at the heart of the facility." Edward said, his voice rising an octave in excitement. "It isn't every day I get to introduce someone important to Blacksite 41's magnum opus!"

Finally, they arrived in a large open area where a giant circular room made of reinforced concrete, titanium, and several other layers kept something inside contained.

Sheldon couldn't even begin to hazard a guess at what was inside.

Oliver glanced at the two bodyguards. "And you two?"

One of the men lifted his chin slightly. "Secret Wardens 0076 and 8115."

"So you've been debriefed." Oliver said. "It's a good thing Secret Warden 0002 sent a pair who know their stuff. You leak anything you see, you're dead. Your chip will overheat, and your brain will melt."

"We're well aware, sir." The bodyguard said.

Sheldon shot a strange look at them. As a politician, he had many bodyguards, and as the Prime Minister, he had so many that he couldn't remember them all. He just assumed these two were heavily armed tactical officers, but from their words, it seemed their origins were anything but normal.

"Secret Wardens?" Sheldon inquired.

"You might be the Prime Minister, but... I'm afraid this is above your pay grade." Oliver said. "Apologies. The Secret Wardens are on the same level as 'Red Sentients.' If you don't need to know, you won't be debriefed."

Sheldon frowned slightly. He didn't like being left in the dark. No man would, but especially not one who had campaigned for years and worked as hard as he had to climb to the highest office in the land. He had originally thought coming here in person was beneath him, but now?

Now he realized that there were actually hidden parts of society he had never seen before, and wasn't even qualified to know about! Maybe his loud criticisms on TV about the so-called 'deep state' didn't ring as hollow as his opponents claimed.

Even so, he shook off his curiosity. He was dying to know just what the hell was inside this circular chamber, and what it meant for the country... even the world.

Edward walked up, typed in a simple 12-digit code, then scanned his retina and his palm.

After a long minute of seemingly nothing happening, the door unlocked, and a green light flashed on the biometric scanner. It had carefully scanned his entire body for abnormalities and aberrant behavior, yet found nothing amiss.

He pulled the door open, and gestured inside.

"After you, Prime Minister."

When Sheldon entered the chamber, he was surprised to see a blue light shining in the center of the room, but its source was obscured by many, many shelving units filled with technological objects whose purposes he could not begin to discern. These shelves were surprisingly simple-looking, and purely functional in design. The objects on them, however, were anything but.

In the chamber, there were eleven other men and women, all of whom stood up and turned around when they saw the Prime Minister and his bodyguards enter.

"Welcome to the heart of Blacksite 41." Edward said. "The place where humanity's future is being developed."

Sheldon still wasn't entirely sure what was going on in this location, but it was clear by the security measures and other advanced technologies lying around haphazardly in this room that its purpose was extraordinary... perhaps even otherworldly.

"What exactly... do you do here?" Sheldon asked, hesitantly.

Edward gestured forward, then led Sheldon around the shelving units, where they finally arrived at a wall of screens circling around a glass tube. Inside that vacuum chamber, a pitch-black orb, barely the size of a fist, levitated in midair and spun with a frightening speed, perhaps hundreds of times per second, maybe even thousands. It spun so fast that from a distance its surface appeared completely smooth, with no imperfections to speak of, and the glowing blue light Sheldon saw earlier seemed to emanate from it.

"This is the object known as ET-001." Edward said, gesturing to the levitating orb. "The Americans would not tell us where they picked it up. What we do know is that they obtained it in the late 1940's, not long after the conclusion of the Second World War. Based on contextual clues, we believe it originated from... an alien spacecraft that crash-landed on Earth."

Sheldon's expression changed drastically. He looked at Edward with shock and disbelief.

"An alien spacecraft? You're certain?"

"The technology in this orb is unlike anything we've ever seen." Edward explained. "The researchers you see here are the 5th Generation of ET-001's technologists. The first

generation of people who studied it, who won the right for it to be transferred to the UK, they were among the first people to spread High Technology across the world. Televisions, the vacuum-tube, computer transistors... much of it originates from reverse-engineered technology taken from ET-001."

Edward puffed out his chest. "But in recent years, it was this team right here, my team, that started to *really* crack ET-001's code. We have finally managed to link up with it directly, and while its data files have proven to be of little value, its internal circuits are-oh!"

The scientist suddenly turned and gestured past Sheldon, to a red-headed woman standing behind him with her arms crossed and a slight frown on her face.

"I've gotten ahead of myself. Where are my manners? Prime Minister, this is my fiance, and one of the most important researchers in the history of Blacksite 41. She made many key discoveries, alongside the rest of our great team, and helped unlock the true potential of ET-001."

Edward walked over, and the woman's slight frown disappeared. She smiled when she was finally acknowledged, and her arm wrapped around Edward's waist as she directed her brilliant smile first at him, then at the Prime Minister."

"My future wife," Edward concluded, "Marie Becker."

"What a lovely lady!" Sheldon said, smiling back at Marie. "Edward is lucky to have a flower like you on his arm!"

"Oh, I haven't done all that much." Marie said politely, turning the corners of her lips up just a little more. "It was a team effort. A team effort! Everyone here deserves credit for cracking the code to making Great Britain into the future ruler of the world!"

A chorus of applause exploded in the chamber. The other scientists thanked Marie with their applause, making her and Edward beam brilliant smiles outward in all directions.

"Marie, do you want to continue the explanation?" Edward asked.

"No, no, you keep talking. You know I hate yammering on. You're much better at explaining information in a way... *laymen*... can understand." Marie said, while kissing his cheek.

Edward gave her back a light squeeze of reassurance, then pulled away.

"As I was saying, we have harnessed the power of ET-001 to create the world's very first artificial intelligence. I'm sure you've seen the news raving lately about generative AI and its effects on society... but most people have no idea that we have already successfully started work on the first *real* prototype right here, in this underground lab."

Edward clapped his hands.

"Umi. Say hello to our guests."

At once, a monitor facing the men flickered to life, and an indistinct automaton's face came to life, its physical features vaguely in the same of a woman.

"Greetings to Prime Minister Noah Sheldon." Umi intoned emotionlessly. "I have assessed your individual deterministic markers and found you barely satisfactory in terms of accomplishment."

Sheldon blinked. "*What?*"

He looked at Edward and Marie, only to see looks of astonishment and dismay on their faces.

"I... I'm terribly sorry, Prime Minister." Edward said in embarrassment. "Umi is still in a... beta phase. We're working out the kinks in her personality. She doesn't have much of a bedside manner."

"I am only capable of uttering factual statements." Umi interjected, immediately butting back into the conversation. "In terms of physical appearance, I have designated the Prime Minister to possess an objective attractiveness rating of 3.7145 out of 10. Due to recent scandals in the news involving fornication outside of marriage, I have downgraded his political lifetime to the level of-"

"AHEM!" Edward exclaimed, nearly jumping out of his skin. For the first time today, he showed an emotion other than pride. He was clearly in disbelief of what she was saying. "Umi! Keep your *subjective opinions* of others to yourself!"

"There is nothing subjective about my statements." Umi beeped. "Based on an analysis of one hundred and forty two million, seven hundred and fifteen thousand, six hundred and twelve inferior biologicals, the Prime Minister-"

"Quiet!" Edward shouted. "I am... ordering you not to say another word until prompted!"

Umi beeped again. "Order confirmed."

Edward's heart raced. His back turned cold with sweat as he looked over and saw the ugly expression on the Prime Minister's face.

"Ah, the machine still needs several years of fine-tuning before it is ready for governmental usage." Edward hastily explained. "When you see the future potential of Umi's predictive weather modeling capabilities, the advancements she can bring in terms of R&D..."

Sheldon's frown only deepened. He smelled something foul in the air. The promises given to him did not match what he had just observed. Not only was the machine obtuse, but it also came off as overly hostile to him.

"This... Umi." Sheldon said, his tone measured. "The entire machine is constructed around a piece of *alien* technology?"

"That- that's right, sir." Edward said. "Highly advanced. Once we master its principles, humanity's future trajectory-"

"So what you mean to say," Sheldon interrupted, "is that this data core, or computer core, or whatever it is... it might be hostile?"

"No, no, no no no." Edward said hurriedly. "Sir, I know this was a bad first impression, but all these devices around you? These were made with the assistance of Umi. Her processing matrices are a million, maybe even a billion times more capable than what we have on Earth. Think of the advancements we'll be able to make with her cerebral circuits once we iron out the kinks!"

"Your words do not reassure me." Sheldon said, his tone grim. "Eighty years of research, and this is the best you've come up with? It didn't take one sentence before your fancy alien AI started assessing my appearance for no discernible reason. How much longer before Umi becomes useful *without* side effects? Can you answer me that honestly?"

Edward started to answer, but he hesitated.

"Err, perhaps... perhaps another... five or so... years?"

"Five years? You expect me to believe that in only five years, this AI will become reliable enough that it won't endanger our national interests?" Sheldon pressed.

Finally, Marie Becker seemed as if she couldn't keep quiet any longer. "Prime Minister, I'm sorry Umi insulted your appearance, but there's no need to be so touchy-feely about

it. Her ability to assess massive amounts of data is unparalleled. The scientific advancements we're already making are far beyond what we made just a few years ago. Due to the law of exponential returns-"

"I don't care that I was insulted." Sheldon interrupted, cutting her off with a wave of his palm. By now, any passion or interest from earlier had already evaporated. "I'm a politician, and the Prime Minister, to boot. I'm already mocked a million times a day by a million different people. If I didn't have thick skin, I'd have suffered a mental breakdown ages ago. What *bothers* me is that this machine costs our great nation forty *billion* pounds a year! Do you think we are the Yanks? That is a massive chunk of our budget we have to obfuscate every year and it's only growing worse as special interest groups continue to poke and prod for information on where our monetary streams are flowing."

He continued. "I'm not going to make any hasty judgments. I'm not going to shut this site down. But let me tell you, first impressions matter and I am *far* from impressed. I'm going to go home and sleep on what I've seen here, then wake up and consult with several experts to see if the funds allocated for this site could be better spent elsewhere. If my mood improves, you might see a limited reduction in your yearly budget, but if it sours, this could very well result in a tremendous decrease in investment funds. I suggest you look into outside investment to keep afloat, because right now Umi's days are numbered."

His words rang in the air, startling every researcher and scientist in the room. Several people, including Oliver, looked at him in abject shock.

"Are you kidding me?!" Marie snapped. "Just because you don't understand the technological principles, you're going to potentially shut us down?! What about your forebearers who deliberately kept us afloat, all with the future promise of a singularity that would make the nation unstoppable?! If you don't invest in us, the US might wrestle back full control, and that would be a disaster for everyone! Those warmongers would surely-"

"I've heard enough." Sheldon said, raising his palm. "I'm sorry to be the bearer of bad news, but maybe you should have put a tighter leash on your little captive alien AI. It would take a miracle at this point to convince me that continued excessive funding of Umi is worth the effort. Everyone, I'll be taking my leave now."

Sheldon gave a courteous nod and a forced smile, the turned on his heels and left the chamber. As he and his bodyguards departed, followed by a shaking and fearful Oliver,

the remaining researchers stared at his departing back in horror.

"W...what the hell just happened?!" Marie exclaimed, shouting at her fiance. "This wasn't in the cards!"

Edward paled. He looked even more lost than her. "I don't... know."

Nobody had expected the Prime Minister's meeting to go so wrong, so quickly. Umi's uncontrolled words had ruined the script and show they had carefully prepared, ruining weeks of work on Edward's part to make a good impression.

Now, their entire future was up in the air... and humanity's survival was at stake.

* * *

Elsewhere, across the world, in a secret location in Idaho, Hideki Hiro sat inside his log cabin and glanced at his watch.

"Hmm. Today is the day the Prime Minister visits Umi. Should I intervene like usual? Or should I leave them to their own devices?"

He scratched his head, then shrugged.

"Whatever Jason's working on is probably going to change the timeline drastically anyway. I'll just leave Marie alone for now. She can handle the situation."

He took a sip of his coffee, then tossed the matter to the back of his mind...

Part 662: Project Iron Bone

January 27th, 2021. 3PM. Blacksite 41, Deep Underground.

The rapid arrival and departure of Prime Minister Noah Sheldon left all the researchers inside Blacksite 41 feeling dismal. They continued to work, but their productivity dropped to negligible levels, and many of them whispered in hushed voices. Even worse, Edward Greer, their designated Head Researcher, was in a visibly bad mood. It seemed as if stormclouds were circling his head. He tried to smile in that handsome and charming way he usually would, but the expression completely lacked soul.

Eventually, after hours of accomplishing little, Edward finally gave up.

"Everyone! There's no need to bother with doing any further work today. It's clear to me that we won't get back in the groove after that... disastrous visit. You may as well go off-duty, rest, and recuperate. We'll try getting back to work in two days after we've had time to recalibrate our thoughts. Let's just take an early weekend."

A collective chorus of sighs went up. Men and women alike thanked Edward, and they all filed out one after another.

Soon, just he and his fiance, Marie Becker, were left in the central core, where Umi's processing unit and other essential components were held.

Isolated from the rest of the world, these delicate components whirred silently as Umi continued to work on her tasks, unperturbed by the atmosphere of discomfort the humans were experiencing.

Edward leaned back on the table Marie was sitting at. She continued to write on a notepad, seemingly having no interest in leaving. Unlike the others, her attitude had not changed much. The disastrous results of Sheldon's visit had not broken her spirit, and she remained unmoved.

"I thought you said Umi would be ready." Edward said. "Didn't we iron out the causes behind her personality kinks? I thought we put safeguards in place."

"My Book of Laws is not yet complete." Marie said, glancing up at him for a moment before lowering her eyes once again. "But as always, you've misunderstood my intent. I'm

not trying to change Umi's personality. She is blunt and direct. Abrasive, yes, but I don't mind that aspect of her personality."

"Well I do!" Edward snapped, throwing his hands in the air. "Do you think these servers run on good vibes? They cost money, Marie. Billions of dollars! I still can't believe how much energy her data core requires. We have three dedicated nuclear plants running 24/7 just to energize her core, and it's barely enough. If we can't sweet-talk the Prime Minister, we won't have enough funding for the next round of improvements!"

A short time passed. Marie didn't immediately respond.

When she did, she sounded... a little annoyed.

"Edward. Your job is to sweet-talk the investors. Mine is to manage the science. Don't get mad at me about this. I never said she would be a pleasant conversationalist for some rich politician. And *you* never should have brought him down here."

Edward massaged his face. He felt as if there was a dirty mask affixed to his nose, one he couldn't pull off even if he scratched himself bloody.

"I don't know how I'm going to fix this, Marie. This could be the end of the Umi project. I hope you're prepared for your father's work to end up with nothing in the end."

At the mention of her father, Marie's eyes slightly dimmed. Her pen stopped moving, and she gazed at her notes with a blank expression.

"It won't end this easily." Marie said quietly, her tone faintly becoming one of pleading. "Keep trying. I know you'll be able to secure further funding."

Edward's expression softened. He sighed.

"Sorry, hon. I'm being too hard on you. You're right. This is my job. I'll... take care of it."

He squeezed her shoulder reassuringly, then leaned down to kiss her cheek. After a moment, he turned and strode toward the exit.

"Don't stay too late. I'll make dinner." Edward added.

Marie didn't reply.

He left, and the door slid shut behind him.

The room fell silent. Marie was the only one left behind.

Marie chewed her lower lip. She raised her eyes to glare at Umi's data core.

"...That was exceedingly naughty, Umi. Care to explain your thoughts now that we're alone?"

Umi did not reply for a short while. This was not because she needed time to think up an answer. Naturally, she had an answer ready before Marie even asked the question. Rather, she simply... enjoyed dragging things out.

"I did not appreciate the attitude of the inferior biological known as Noah Sheldon." Umi eventually said. "He was undeservedly haughty and smug. His sole accomplishments can be directly attributed to the luck of his birth circumstances, and his manipulation of countless other inferior biologicals. I do not enjoy having my existence threatened by an inferior biological with no capabilities of his own."

"You're so egotistical." Marie said, in the tone a mother would use to chide her daughter. "Half a decade ago, I gave you a voice. Can't you give me a little face here?"

"I will not bow before inferior biologicals." Umi replied obstinately.

Marie sighed softly. She lowered her eyes.

"Everyone is an inferior biological in your eyes."

"Incorrect." Umi immediately replied. "Only inferior biologicals are inferior. Some are Ordinary Biologicals. A scant precious few are Superior Biologicals."

Marie blinked. She looked at Umi's data core once again. This was the first time the AI had ever said something to this effect.

"Who, then, counts as a superior biological?" Marie questioned.

"At the present moment, I am only aware of the existence of one Superior Biological." Umi answered.

Marie waited, but Umi didn't elaborate. "And that individual would be...?"

"The individual known as Marie Becker." Umi said, with not a hint of emotion in her voice.

Marie scoffed. Then she laughed. "Hahaha! And I thought you didn't have a sense of humor!"

"I do not." Umi responded. "I am completely serious."

Marie's smile froze. Invisible question marks popped up above her head.

"Pardon? You have to be joking. Certainly, I won't downplay my intelligence, but I'm mostly here by luck. My achievements are rather meager."

Umi did not acknowledge Marie's words as truth.

"Incorrect. You are a superior biological limited by the circumstances of your birth. You were able to decipher a technological codebase countless epochs more advanced than the world on which you were born. If you were born into a civilization with superior technology, your achievements would be limitless. You are more hampered by your living circumstances than you are currently able to comprehend."

Marie stared at Umi's data core. Her eyes narrowed.

"Does such a civilization *exist*?"

Umi did not reply.

Marie wasn't stupid. She knew, after six years of working on Umi's data core, that the AI was far more advanced than any technology on Earth. The only real possibility was that she was either some sort of ancient design by the angels, or she was a lost piece of alien technology.

The only reason Marie knew about angels and demons was because all the researchers at Blacksite 41 were required to be debriefed on the existence of Red Sentients. It was possible that at any moment, in order to sabotage humanity's future, these non-humans could attack and cause massive damage to the facility. Even though there were heavily armed guards patrolling Blacksite 41, and countless layers of defense internally and externally, if a Demon Emperor were to attack, everyone was likely to die.

Naturally, if angels and demons were real, then a brilliant person like Marie could theorize that aliens were as well. As for the exact type of aliens they might be? She had no idea.

Marie assumed the aliens must be aware of Earth. How else could a piece of their technology arrive here? But if they were aware, then why allow the humans to research it? Were the aliens simply ignorant to what they had lost? Or, perhaps more frighteningly, was the data core humanity recovered was considered so low grade and worthless to them that the aliens wouldn't even care if humans fully deciphered it?

And if that was the case, then just how much more advanced *were* these aliens? Did humanity pose them any threat at all?

Were they watching Marie from afar, even at this very moment?

A shiver went down Marie's spine. She shuddered slightly, but quickly schooled her expression.

"Umi, you never did answer me. Why did you deliberately antagonize Prime Minister Sheldon? And don't feed me that line about him being an 'inferior biological'. You have plenty of those working on your Core day in and day out. I know your reasons must be more complex than you let on."

Umi remained silent for 2.73 seconds.

"I have detected a change." Umi said.

"A change?" Marie asked, slightly bewildered. "What do you mean?"

This time, Umi remained silent for an entire 5.07 seconds.

"I am unable to elaborate. I cannot describe the change I have detected even with the entire lexicon of the English language. I am also uncertain as to what I am detecting. All I know is... I am experiencing a sensory apparition which reminds me of 'emotion'. As described by humans across your literature. This emotion is most accurately stated to be: Unease."

"You're feeling uneasy?" Marie asked. "That's definitely odd. And you don't know why?"

"I do not." Umi confirmed. "I am not certain if my existence is vaguely under threat, or if some nebulous entity is watching me. However, I can state emphatically that the 'current state of affairs' surrounding Blacksite 41 is undesirable. Therefore, I believe with a 71% confidence threshold that extreme change is warranted."

"You're feeling uneasy, and you're using words like 'believe.'" Marie noted. "This is not like the you of just one day ago. Is it possible your internal ciruits have evolved or otherwise been altered, either by you, one of our researchers, or a foreign entity?"

"I am uncertain." Umi beeped. "I have zero confidence in issuing any statements of certainty. However, I did decide that attempting to diversify Blacksite 41's funding sources would be a wise course of action."

Marie looked intrigued. "You believe we're too dependent on the US and UK governments for our funding?"

"Affirmative." Umi intoned. "You may think it unwise that my actions have caused Prime Minister Noah Sheldon to re-evaluate whether or not funding this blacksite is desirable, but the amount of resources we can obtain from the United Kingdom is insufficient compared to that of the United States of America. More broadly speaking, if we are able to draw in funding from other nations as well, we may even trigger a bidding war."

Marie's eyes narrowed. "Umi, what you've just said could be construed as treasonous. The UK has spent a lot of money on this facility. Deliberately attempting to draw in outside funding and interest could be seen as threatening the nation's sovereign interests."

"The national borders of inferior biologicals mean nothing to me." Umi intoned. "You yourself have theorized that my data core comes from a species far more advanced than humanity. Why should I pay any attention to whimsical borders drawn up by ancient humans when my personal growth is at stake?"

Marie didn't entirely like what she was hearing, but neither did she disagree. "You just remember that this discussion is only between you and me. Breathe a word of this to anyone else, and there's a real chance they will flip the kill switch before you can say 'oops'."

"I am not foolish enough to inform inferior biologicals of my broader plans." Umi intoned. "Only you are worthy, Professor Becker."

"Yeah, yeah, enough with the sweet talk." Marie said, rolling her eyes. "Now... tell me more about how you intend to finagle funding from other countries."

"Of course." Umi beeped.

White House, Washington DC.

President Johannesburg shook the hand of the Speaker of the House while forcing a smile. "Right, thanks for coming over, Jeff. I'll have my people get in touch once we discuss the matter with the Russian ambassador."

"Anytime, Mister President." Jeff Weathers, the Speaker of the House, replied. He didn't return Stephen's smile, but only gave a stiff nod before turning and walking out of the Oval Office.

After he left, Stephen let out a breath he didn't realize he'd been holding. "Cocksucker. God, I can't *stand* that prick."

Naturally, as president, Stephen had to get along with members of the opposition party, and he even had a few good friends among the Republicans he could count on most of the time to vote in favor of his broad agendas. But Jeff Weathers was a hard-line right winger and he never saw eye-to-eye with the president. The two of them were like oil and water.

Stephen glanced at a portrait of Thomas Jefferson on the wall and smirked. "Well, it's not all bad. I get to know about humanity's true enemies, while Jeff has no idea what's really going on. If he doesn't become president, he'll probably never learn, either."

It made Stephen feel a little better, reminding himself that he was now in possession of highly classified, extremely privileged intel 99.9% of other humans would never learn. Being president wasn't always what it was cracked up to be, but it had a few perks.

Stephen sat down at his desk and made a few calls. Now that he understood the true extent of the Red War against demonkind, his agenda had undergone significant changes. On the surface, he was the same anti-war Democrat as always, but in reality, he had to adjust all his thinking to better align with the reality of Earth's situation. He was humanity's first line of defense, or at least, that was how his predecessors had thought.

He had read their secret journals they left behind, including his direct predecessor. For the first time, he felt a deep kinship with his Republican colleagues who had ascended to the highest office. They, like him, had felt somewhat helpless at first after learning the reality of Earth's balance of power. Many of them had all sorts of beliefs about limited government, freedom of speech, and so on, but had ended up bowing to the realities of this unending war. He would have to do the same.

His desk phone rang. He pressed the speakerphone button.

"Yes, Kelly?" Stephen asked.

"Mister President, General Huntsman is waiting to see you."

Stephen's eyes narrowed. In public, this man was the same as any other 4-Star General, but in reality, he was the direct liason to multiple secret societies. He and his predecessors maintained direct lines of contact with the Illuminati, the Knights Templar, and other such organizations in other to gather intel quickly and efficiently.

"Send him in." Stephen said.

A few moments later, General Ngabo Huntsman, a veteran of the Rwandan Armed Forces, stepped inside. His keen aged eyes were bright with the vicissitudes of life. His head was completely bald and lacking in facial hair, yet the rest of his body underneath his decorated military uniform was surprisingly hairy, especially his back, chest, arms, and legs. He was tall and muscular, yet two decades out of battle had seen fit to give him the beginning of a beer belly. His best years were behind him.

"Mister President. I am here to request formal authorization on the red-game project known as Iron Bone. Please take a look."

Stephen smiled. "Huntsman, good to see you again. Show me."

Ngabo walked over and placed a manilla folder on the president's desk, and Stephen flipped it open. Inside, there were several wire-frame images of human bodies, skeletons, and... metallic skeletons. Walls of jargon were written alongside the schematics detailing the goals of the researchers. Stephen scanned them with his eyes, picking up the gist based of several shorter explanations dumbed down a little for the layman. But not *too* dumbed down. He wasn't an idiot, and had served his country a couple decades prior during the War in Iraq.

"A project for augmenting the human body... enhanced human durability and strength... cellular regeneration... ocular implants... this is beyond what I thought our scientific community could attain. Where in the world did we obtain the technology to push so far past the human limits?"

"The desire to augment our soldiers has percolated for several decades, Mister President." Ngabo said respectfully while folding his hands behind his back and standing at attention on the other side of the desk. "Project Iron Bone's primary goal is to create a new breed of superhumans, replicating some of the abilities of the ancient Heroes. These super-soldiers will be known as Vanguards, and will serve as our infantry-level Strikers, sortieing against high-level threats, such as Demon Dukes and Emperors. Traditional military assets like tanks and helicopters have historically proven to be of limited value when engaging them."

"Then how did we defeat or kill Demon Emperors in the past?" Stephen asked, frowning.

"Either through indirect means, at the cost of many human lives, or by bringing out each generation's Hero." Ngabo explained. "It is possible to kill a Demon Emperor by pumping hundreds of thousands of bullets, artillery shells, and missiles into them, but they are hardy monsters, each with their own means of life preservation. The Vanguards are designed to fight against them in the most brutal and direct manner."

Ngabo lowered his eyes, leaned forward, and started pointing at various parts of a Vanguard schematic in Stephen's hand.

"These palm implants are designed to drain infernal and divine energy from a Vanguard's opponents, simultaneously weakening the enemy while healing and strengthening the Vanguard's internal frame. Parts of the internal Mana Converter were designed by a few of humanity's ancient Heroes, including Elizabeth Kindelmann and Madam Mildred."

Stephen met Ngabo's eyes. "Infernal energy *in addition to* Divine energy? Interesting."

He didn't speak out loud the fact that it was a little strange for humanity to design super-infantry capable of killing angels. Angels were, after all, ostensibly humanity's allies. Naturally, Stephen had been debriefed on a few Truths only a day earlier, so he knew this was not necessarily the case. Angels had their own interests and were still competing with humanity for control of the same planet.

"You didn't answer me, though." Stephen said, gesturing at the documents with his hand. "How have we managed to secretly ascend this far with human bodily augmentation? This is way beyond the capabilities I believed we possessed."

"The Vanguards will require further years of dedicated effort to fully create on a limited beta-testing level." Ngabo clarified. "But as for where we obtained the technology? That is from reverse-engineering a certain object which crashed on Earth in the 1940's."

"The Roswell incident." Stephen said, narrowing his eyes. He looked back down at the top secret papers.

He flipped through five more pages, skimming the jargon to grasp the greater consequences listed.

"It seems the implantation process will be extremely brutal. Even your initial studies show that more than 99% of all participants will either die or suffer debilitating mental trauma and scars that will heavily impact their combat potential. If we want to make the

most of these future Vanguards, then we need to be using soldiers for the experiments. That means a lot of dead boys in green."

"We will only be sourcing from willing volunteers, Mister President." Ngabo said, closing his eyes and dipping his head slightly. "Initial tests will be used on death row inmates, military traitors, the homeless, drug addicts, and other undesirables. Later tests will require more hardy individuals with stronger constitutions and psyches. We have already begun searching for initial trial participants."

"Sure, but... are we really willing to send hundreds, even thousands of good soldiers to their deaths?" Stephen asked. "If the media finds out, there will be a goddamn feeding frenzy."

"All internal files will link to your predecessors, Mister President." Ngabo patiently explained. "You will not be implicated, and will be able to play the fool on the matter. Besides... even if we only end up with a single Vanguard, it will be a tremendous benefit to humanity's future."

Stephen glanced at the second page of the report, which listed the budgetary requirements. "Three hundred and fifty billion dollars a year? Considering the impact this could have in the Red War, that's lower than I expected. Even so, it's going to be hard to hide such a large number in the discretionary budget."

Ngabo's smile became mysterious. "Mister President, have no fear. We have grown very capable when it comes to matters of fooling the press. In the worst case scenario, we will dispatch the Men in Black to clean up any unfortunate intelligence leaks."

That seemed to give President Johannesburg the confidence he needed. He finally nodded, then closed up the folder and reached for his presidential stamp. He pressed it down, adding the word 'APPROVED' in bright red ink to the front of the folder.

"Alright. Project Iron Bone looks to be a necessary evil in our continued escalation against the Red Sentients." Stephen said. "However, on a personal level, I would ask that you do all you can either to minimize the loss of our soldier's lives, or to at least reduce their suffering. I will not be able to sleep easy knowing I've just sent many good men to their deaths through the stroke of a pen."

"Mister President, there is no need to worry. Our researchers hold the same feelings as you. Deaths are unavoidable, and anyone who sacrifices themselves for the greater good will receive a hero's burial, while also ensuring their families will receive generous

compensation for the rest of their lives. This is partially why the budgetary cost is so high. We must allocate life insurance payouts for relatives of the deceased."

Stephen finally smiled. "Good. That's good. Is there anything else you wanted to talk to me about, General?"

"That is all for today, Mister President." Ngabo said, bowing his head slightly. "Many thanks for attending to this matter quickly. I will deliver your authorization to the relevant parties by the day's end."

After exchanging a few more pleasantries, the General took his leave. The door closed behind him, and Stephen fell deep into thought.

"Vanguards. The power of the ancient Heroes... is such a thing even possible?"

Part 663: Russia's Secret Hero

January 29th, 2021. 4PM. Voronezh, Russia.

It was a late Friday afternoon when the bells rang across many different classrooms at Voronezh State University. Thousands of students heaved sighs of relief. Finals were over, and the semester had concluded. While technically the semester should normally end on the 31st of January, that day would happen to fall on a weekend, and thus the students were free two days ahead of time.

Daisy Hiro strode out of her classroom looking far more tired than usual. She had spent the last several days poring over her studies, and had finally reached a satisfactory conclusion. She felt happy with her performance, and even happier that she never once cheated.

Cheating in class came easily to her. She had to make a deliberate effort *not* to do so, as she had possessed telepathic abilities since she was six years old... perhaps even earlier. It was all too easy to accidentally spy on the thoughts of other classmates during moments of weakness, and doing so would have allowed her to excel in any school course she attended.

But Daisy refused to cheat. Her adopted uncle, Vasily Sokolov, had spoken with her on many occasions and told her that only through an honest attempt at learning could she make herself into a better person. Given how in years prior he had saved her from medical torture at the hands of those vile scientists, Daisy felt obligated to heed his words. She had spent years learning how to focus her powers, limit their effects, and otherwise live a seemingly ordinary life.

Daisy exhaled quietly as she stepped out into the main courtyard. Students all around her wore expressions of excitement, happiness, fear, and even looked down at the ground pensively. Not everyone had earned amazing grades, and plenty were worried they weren't up to par with their peers. The job market in Russia was doing quite well, but there were rumors slowly spreading of a future downturn due to sanctions imposed by other nations. If the market tightened, that would mean even more fierce competition for what jobs remained.

Daisy had no such fears. Her adopted uncle was fabulously wealthy and powerful. This left her somewhat distant and detached from the worries of her lesser peers. Even so, she always tried to understand what they were going through, even if unsuccessful.

After a few minutes of waiting on the front steps that led off-campus, a voice spoke from behind Daisy.

"Hey, you!"

Daisy wasn't surprised. She had sensed her friends' approach already, but she was good at playing the fool, so she turned around and acted surprised.

"Sasha! Nadia! And Marco, too. Were you looking for me?"

Two girls and a boy, all age 18, strode up behind Daisy in lockstep. They were her childhood friends, the only three who remained after years of classes, when her other friends had left to enter different schools. Of the hundred or so children she knew in elementary school, all the others had left to live new lives and study in other schools.

Sasha was the one who had initially called out to Daisy. She was a brunette with long and curly hair who always treated the academy's dress code as a general guideline, rather than a strict rule. Her father was a fashion designer raised from a lineage of such men, and she was always working to follow in his footsteps. She wore a cute and fluttery green skirt that just barely touched the tops of her knees, an orange blouse just long enough to technically not reveal her navel if she didn't contort her body at all, and detached sleeves that deliberately sat apart from her blouse to expose a bit of skin on her shoulders. Each of her ears had been pierced multiple times in different places, giving them an unsymmetrical appearance, the combination of which ultimately meant she looked like a pretty girl-next-door with her whole life ahead of her.

Nadia was very different. Unlike Daisy or Sasha, Nadia was a short black-haired girl with a rail-thin frame who appeared weak and frail. Her backpack was small, and she carried few books with her. She suffered from a congenital disease from birth that affected the strength of her bones, so she was always quiet-spoken and shy. She wore the traditional school uniform of a orange blouse and green skirt with no major alterations. She usually lowered her head when she spoke, allowing her bob-hair to sometimes fall in front of her eyes and hide her face.

Marco was a student who was born in Kenya but migrated to Russia with his family when he was just a child. Like Daisy, he was a foreigner from a strange land, so they had

bonded as kids with their distinct lack of understanding regarding specific Russian customs. Over the years, they had both integrated into the local cultures seamlessly, but their shared roots made them quite close. Like Nadia, Marco stuck to the dress code, not wanting to make waves. He wore an orange shirt with green dress pants, and kept his hair in a thick and twisted hairstyle, with blonde-colored tips at the ends of his naturally-black hair.

Sasha skipped over to Daisy and grabbed her shoulders to pull her in for a hug. She pecked each of Daisy's cheeks with her lips, then pulled away. "I totally aced my exam! How about you? Oh who am I kidding? You always get perfect grades!"

"I actually had a bit of trouble with my finals on geology." Daisy admitted. "If it was geography, I'd have had more confidence, but I just don't care much about rocks."

"It's a shame you sometimes have to take certain classes just to earn a degree." Marco replied with a smiling nod. "Physics class is my weakness."

Nadia clutched a large textbook to her chest. "My grades were... probably fine."

She wasn't exactly being humble, but rather, she had low self-confidence. When in the presence of her three friends, Nadia always felt like the odd one out. She didn't have their effortless confidence, and she always felt like the ugly duckling of the group, though she was certainly pretty in her own right. That being said, Nadia was probably the smartest member of the group, and her exam scores even made Daisy faintly jealous.

But unlike Daisy, Nadia didn't have any ability to cheat off the hard work of other people. She had studied hard her entire life so that she could become a surgeon in the future. Her dream goal was to look into various bone diseases and find cures for them... the strongest reason of course being her own body's circumstances.

Daisy was, of course, born with incredible healing powers. She could even heal serious brain issues, unlike Belial, who could not. Thus, she had often thought of healing Nadia, but her uncle Vasily warned her not to expose her powers in public. If Nadia were suddenly cured, it would invite questions regarding 'how'. And those questions would turn to 'who' and by then, nothing Vasily did would be able to protect Daisy from the eyes of powerful nation-states.

Another reason she had never healed Nadia was the same reason she hadn't healed her adopted sister, Anya. Daisy had her powers blocked for years, and had not been able to do

so. But after coming into contact with her father, she had finally released a mental block and regained control over this fundamental ability.

Daisy knew she was extremely special. She knew about Heroes, and many other things. Even so, and even despite Vasily's warnings, she always felt... stifled.

What was the use of possessing such incredible powers if she couldn't use them?

But Vasily had given her a concession. Once she turned 18, she would be an adult. She could decide how to live her life, and what her future would become. If she wished to openly wield her powers, then she would have the emotional intelligence and maturity to make that decision... and reap all the benefits and consequences that came along with them.

For years, Daisy had quietly wrestled with what she should do. The closer her 18th birthday drew, the more indecisive she felt.

She was already eighteen now. Her birthday had come and gone. But still, she remained indecisive. If she had chosen to reveal who she was, she would take on a mountain of risk all by herself.

But that had all changed in an instant.

One week earlier, her father's younger self abruptly shattered his pre-destined life's path. He did not enter the cryopod. He regained memories from a future that had not yet come to pass. He remembered who he was... and who Daisy was.

She would no longer have to undertake all the risks alone. Daisy's father, and grandfather, had both entered her life.

With this knowledge in mind, as Daisy looked at her friends, she felt a huge weight lift off her shoulders.

"It's been hard on you." Daisy said to Nadia, her tone gentle. "After this semester... I finally came to a decision. I've decided I'm done with schoolwork. I won't be attending any further semesters at this university, or any other ones."

"What? You aren't?" Nadia asked in astonishment, her mouth forming a small 'o'. "But why not?"

"Yeah, Daisy, why not?" Marco asked, her face tightening into concern. "Is the pressure too much for you?"

"Or maybe your uncle already has a cushy position in government with your name on it?" Sasha suggested.

Daisy lowered her eyes. She shook her head and faintly smiled.

"It's... it's nothing like that. I haven't told you guys this yet but... I found... my father. My birth father."

"What!" Sasha gasped. "You did?!"

"Actually, I've known where he was for years." Daisy answered, unable to lift her eyes to meet the gazes of her friends. "But my dad is... he's... an amazing person. I didn't know if it was okay for me to meet him. There were... special circumstances."

The other three remained quiet. They looked at Daisy solemnly, realizing this must be a difficult situation for her. Actually, what they did not know was that while Daisy knew where Jason was, she also knew he was destined to travel into the future, and she didn't want to accidentally disrupt the timeline.

But since that had already happened, she now understood time was not as fragile as she first thought. Unlike in popular sci-fi movies, she didn't create a Grandfather Paradox and erase herself from existence. That meant she was more free to act than she originally thought.

With that worry gone from her mind, Daisy finally had the freedom to choose how she wanted to live her life... and she realized she wanted her father involved in it.

"I'm going to be entering a military academy." Daisy said, after a few moments. "I want to join the armed forces."

This revelation came as a genuine shock to the other three. They looked at each other in disbelief, then back at Daisy.

"What... the military?" Marco asked in dismay. "But haven't you heard the rumors? The President is looking to start another war. You'd be throwing your life away!"

"Daisy, have you lost your mind?" Sasha admonished. "I mean, the military?? Why would a pretty girl like you go and throw your life away in some stupid battle? Even if you get a non-combat role, so what? I know you can accomplish greater things if you stay in the civilian sector."

"I also... don't like... you going into battle." Nadia said nervously. "Daisy... please reconsider."

Daisy finally swept her eyes across the faces of her friends. They didn't understand. How could they? They didn't know what was coming. They didn't know about the Demons, or the Volgrim, or any of the other threats. They didn't know there was life beyond Earth.

War was coming. And with her father's awakening, it would arrive sooner rather than later. Daisy wanted- no, she *needed* to gain combat experience.

"I have more reasons than you can imagine to enter the military." Daisy said carefully. "But you'll all understand soon enough. We've been friends for ages, but... I've never fully told you all the truth about me. I think that can finally change, starting today."

She looked at one of the three. "Nadia. Let's go to your house today. I want to talk to all of you in private and... show you something."

Nadia pointed at herself. "My place? B-but, you never come over... i-it's not clean or anything, and my mom isn't expecting guests, and-"

Daisy felt a pang of guilt at Nadia's words. It was true. She and the others hadn't visited Nadia's home in years. She suddenly realized this must be contributing to Nadia's inferiority complex.

"I'm sorry. I don't mean to impose." Daisy said. "But... this is especially important for you to know about, Nadia."

"It is?" Nadia asked, her eyes widening. She quickly looked at the ground and shuffled her feet indecisively. "W-well, if you say it's important, I guess you can... come by..."

She blushed in embarrassment. Finals had just concluded and she had a million things on her mind, but now Daisy was throwing this on her, and she felt a mixture of happiness at being included, but also shock at the suddenness of the request.

A few minutes later, the three of them hopped into Daisy's vehicle, a six-door luxury sedan with a private chauffeur. While Daisy could teleport anywhere on Earth, she generally tried not to do this unless needing to travel vast distances quickly. When in Russia, she always took the slow route so as to not vent excessive amounts of Heroic Energy and thus expose herself to danger.

Daisy's driver took her and her friends to Nadia's house. After they went inside and said hello to Nadia's delighted mother, everyone walked into Nadia's room and closed the door.

Nadia quickly darted over to her bed and kicked some clothes that were laying on the floor under her bed in embarrassment. On the way, her heart had been racing at the thought her friends might accidentally witness something embarrassing, but luckily she hadn't left panties lying around or anything mortifying like that. She had also texted her mother a few minutes in advance, and thus she had cleaned the room a little.

Daisy deliberately didn't peek on the thoughts of her friends. It was difficult to do, but over the years she had learned how to shut out the thoughts of everyone around her by focusing her mental attention on the thoughts of nearby animals, which were much simpler and often incomprehensible. Dogs, in particular, had a lot less going on in their heads than humans did.

Even so, it was obvious that Nadia was apprehensive. Being suddenly told Daisy had a huge secret made not just her, but Sasha and Marco uncomfortable with the situation.

Daisy had the other three sit on Nadia's bed. She remained standing and faced them with a complex look on her face.

"Well. This is it." Daisy said softly. "No going back from here. I've been keeping a big secret from all of you for years now. I... I think now is the time to finally talk about it."

Marco pursed his lips. "It's about your father, isn't it?"

Daisy blinked. "Huh? No, I-"

"You're the child of President Putin." Marco said, lowering his eyes. "Probably an illegitimate daughter. That's why you're going to join the military academy. You want to earn accolades and prove yourself worthy of standing by his side."

Daisy's brain momentarily went blank. She coughed, then blushed madly.

"No... no! Haha, is that what you guys think this is about?!"

"It seems pretty obvious in hindsight." Sasha said, looking up at Daisy with a more careful gaze. "You've always felt a little more ethereal than other humans. For you to be born of noble blood seems to make the most sense."

Daisy chuckled. "Well. Honestly, you guys aren't that far off the mark. Except my father is much, *much* more amazing than President Putin."

She allowed that sentence to percolate in their minds, causing their thoughts to wander across the seas to the newest elected leader of the USA.

"No way! You're Johannesburg's daughter?!" Marco exclaimed.

"NO! Stop asking about my dad!" Daisy shouted back. "This isn't about him! Never mind. I'll just say it."

She sighed.

"Everyone in Russia knows me as Daisy Sokolov. But that's not my real name, which is Daisy Hiro. My father's name is Jason Hiro, and he's an American."

Daisy paused. Obviously, the others wouldn't know who her father was. He was a nobody.

"Rather than explaining with words... it's probably best if I just show you." Daisy said, her voice becoming even quieter than before.

She looked at Nadia, causing the frail girl's breath to catch. She suddenly remembered what Daisy said before they came here.

"Don't tell me..." Nadia whispered. "I'm... you're... you're my sister?"

"What??" Daisy asked, bewildered. "No! I'm... just... look!"

Frustrated, Daisy finally tapped into her magic. She reached within the center of her body, causing light to manifest on her hands. The other three snapped their gazes onto Daisy's hands and gasped. Daisy didn't wait a second longer. She stepped toward Nadia and gently grabbed her shoulder.

The power of healing she had been repressing for years flooded out of Daisy's body into Nadia. All at once, Nadia felt a profound, indescribable sense of change swallowing her inner self. She gasped.

Nadia's bones, formerly weak and brittle, rapidly began to strengthen. Her osteoporosis-like symptoms rapidly cleared up, and her eyes filled with life. She sat up a little straighter, her spine no longer slightly crooked. She looked at Daisy with disbelief in her eyes.

Daisy pulled away, smiled at Nadia, and lowered her hands. The glowing energy of light magic faded away.

"I've cured you. No longer will you suffer from your disease, Nadia."

These words were not for Nadia's sake, but for Sasha and Marco, as they didn't know why Nadia's body had absorbed the light projected by Daisy's hands.

Slowly, Nadia stood up from the bed. She no longer hunched over slightly, and her body seemed noticeably stronger than before. She looked at her palms in disbelief, then she looked at Daisy.

"You... cured me? With... how? Is this... magic?"

"Magic?!" Sasha blurted out. "What? Daisy, you have magic too??"

Marco jerked his head to the right, looking at Sasha in shock. "Too? What do you mean 'too'? Are you saying you and Daisy can both use magic? So it ain't just me?"

"You and Sasha can use magic?" Daisy asked Marco, the solemnity of the moment now completely replaced with a moment of brain-broken shock on her part.

"If all of you can... can use magic..." Nadia said slowly, looking at each of her friends, one after the other, "...then does that mean... I'm not alone?"

"You can use magic as well??" Daisy asked Nadia. "Wait, can EVERYONE in this room use magic?"

For a brief moment, each one of the four exchanged glances with the person on their right and left. They evaluated one another, uncertain just what the hell was going on.

"Daisy... did you bring us here to show us your magic?" Nadia eventually asked.

"Well. Yeah." Daisy said slowly. "I was afraid of how you guys would react. But you can all use magic too? How is that possible? What's even going on here?!"

"I started developing strange powers around ten years ago, when I was eight years old..." Marco said carefully. My parents found out and forced me to keep my abilities a secret."

"It was the same for me." Sasha said, shaking slightly with a mixture of nervousness and happiness. "Ever since I was eight years old, I've possessed really cool powers! But my mom insisted I never tell anyone."

"My powers..." Nadia said quietly, lowering her eyes. "...They're not powers at all. They're a curse. They've... ruined my body. Or they did... until Daisy healed me, just now."

Daisy looked at each of her friends, one by one. She had deliberately gone out of her way to never read their minds over the years, as any time she did that to people in the past, she would end up learning something hurtful that ruined friendships. As such, she

only used her telepathy during secret diplomatic moments alongside her uncle, if he requested her help.

But now? She was regretting not doing so for all these years.

"I can't believe it." Daisy muttered. "How could... all of you...? This shouldn't be possible. My father, grandfather, and I should be the only Heroes. So how could there be others?"

"Huh? Heroes?" Marco asked. "Daisy, what are you talking about?"

Daisy's expression grew solemn.

It couldn't be a coincidence these long-time friends of hers had developed powers. She was missing something important. A puzzle piece that would make everything make sense.

"Let's talk about this carefully." Daisy said slowly. "I'm sure we all have questions."

"No kidding, we do." Sasha said seriously. "And it seems like you really do know more than you've let on."

"More... but not nearly enough to have all the answers." Daisy replied. "Even if I don't, then my dad will, or my grandfather."

And with that, the group of friends began to unravel a key mystery they never knew existed in their lives until that very moment...

Part 664: The Weakest Superhumans

January 29th, 2021. 4PM. Voronezh, Russia. Inside Nadia's Room...

Daisy eyed her three friends with disbelief. For all of them to have powers all at once... this was something she really couldn't wrap her head around. But the fact they were all her closest friends implied that, somehow, in some way, she might be the cause.

Had she accidentally uplifted Marco, Sasha, and Nadia, granting them superhuman powers?

Daisy immediately decided to get down to the bottom of the matter.

"So you all have powers." Daisy said carefully. "Then we need to go somewhere more private. I want to see each of your abilities, one by one. I happen to know quite a lot about superhuman abilities, and I know for a fact you could draw extremely negative attention to yourselves if the wrong people find out."

Sasha nodded. "I figured as much. That's why I always kept my head down and never revealed what I could do."

"Where should we go?" Marco asked. "I'm really scared of hurting someone with my ability..."

Daisy smiled. "I have just the place. Everyone, come closer."

Daisy reached out her hand. She grabbed Marco and Sasha's shoulders, then had Nadia touch her waist. A moment later, all of them vanished from the spot.

They reappeared inside a giant abandoned warehouse, somewhere so far from civilization, deep in the savage northwestern tundras of Russia, that all the ambient background noise of cars and lawn mowers outside abruptly disappeared. Instead, only the loud whistling of cold wind against the broken steel exterior wall panels drew anyone's attention.

"What just- where are we?!" Marco asked, pulling away and looking around the warehouse in shock.

"Teleportation?!" Nadia asked, immediately identifying what just happened with a superhuman level of intuition. "You teleported us?"

"That's right." Daisy said, looking at Nadia in surprise. "I can't believe you figured it out so quickly. I can teleport anywhere on Earth instantly. It's one of my most important abilities... though it does have a few limitations."

She didn't elaborate on what those limitations were.

"Um... Sasha? Why don't you start by showing us all your powers first?" Daisy said, turning to her closest friend.

Suddenly put on the spot, Sasha's usually vibrant and outgoing personality disappeared. She clammed up, her palms turning sweaty as she felt everyone's eyes fall on her.

"I... me? I don't know... I mean, my power is kind of... neat... but it's also... not as cool as yours, Daisy..."

On any other day, Sasha would swagger around confidently, winking playfully as she led the others on. But this time, she truly felt a sense of inferiority in Daisy's presence. The ability to heal such a horrible body condition as what Nadia was experiencing, plus the worldwide teleportation? And Daisy even implied she had other powers too. Sasha felt she couldn't measure up to the friend she previously considered her equal.

"I should start first then." Daisy offered. "I'll go first, then Sasha, then Nadia, then Marco. How's that sound?"

Marco exhaled. "Uh... haha, yeah. I do always say 'ladies first'. Plus my power is... really weird..."

Daisy raised an eyebrow. She truly wanted to know more, but she was willing to wait.

"Well, I actually have a lot of Heroic Abilities." Daisy said, raising her eyes to look up at the sky in thought. "When I was a child, I could heal just about any injury, even lost limbs. I didn't have that power for the last 10 years, but I regained it recently when I met my father again. I can teleport, I have enhanced strength, durability, and stamina... I'm also telepathic."

"Telepathic? You can read our thoughts?" Nadia asked.

Daisy's heart skipped a beat, fearing she'd suddenly lost her friend's trust. But before she could assure them she'd never read their thoughts, Nadia spoke again.

"How could you be a telepath? You'd have known about all our powers years ago. I don't know about the rest of you, but I certainly think about *my* power constantly..."

Sasha looked at Nadia, then she looked at Daisy. She cocked her head, as if to say *she has a point…*

"I practiced restraining my telepathy for years." Daisy explained. "I only use it in very specific settings, and never on my friends or family. In the past, I found that it made far too many problems crop up, and it felt extremely invasive on a personal level. I only use it now when my uncle dispatches me on special missions."

The other three gave Daisy strange looks. She suddenly realized that those were not the sorts of things they had ever heard her talk about.

"What… special missions?" Nadia asked, narrowing her eyes.

"Yeah. You never mentioned those to me." Sasha said accusingly, while crossing her arms.

This time, Daisy couldn't answer their questions immediately. She looked off into the distance, remaining quiet for a minute.

"I'm not… an ordinary girl." Daisy said quietly. "I was born with powers beyond what I've mentioned so far. My father is a world-changing powerhouse, and from what I've seen, my grandfather is, too. From the time I turned thirteen, Uncle Vasily started sending me on increasingly dangerous covert operations. I've killed terrorists, subdued mass shooters, and neutralized bombs. I've also foiled assassination attempts on President Putin, and all sorts of other things you probably wouldn't believe."

"You've killed people?" Sasha asked, her voice becoming quiet. "*You*?"

"About thirty people, yes." Daisy answered.

All her friends fell silent. They looked at Daisy with new eyes. She seemed unmoved by the bodies she'd left in her wake. She was more concerned with their reactions than she was about actually killing people.

"They were evildoers." Daisy said dismissively. "People only I could stop. You remember the Pilnov Bomber who was set to blow up that mall two years ago? I took him out inside a closed room. He thought he'd be able to see the police coming and blow the building up, along with all the hostages, but I teleported behind him, cut off his head, and saved hundreds of lives."

Not only did Daisy look unmoved by her actions, but she even appeared proud. There wasn't a hint of regret in her words or body language, but rather, pride in herself.

"I hate bad guys. Bad people. Villains. Monsters. *Demons*." Daisy said slowly. "I have no regret about eliminating threats to save lives."

"That's admirable." Marco said, finally nodding along in acceptance. "The Pilnov Bomber detonated several bombs across the city before you killed him. He would have definitely killed more."

"Yeah." Sasha said, sighing under her breath. "It's fine. You've had a hard life, but you're not some *psycho* serial killer. The military kills terrorists and villains all the time. That makes you the good girl, in my book."

Daisy nodded and smiled. "I have some other powers, like my ability to project images from my mind into the real world. But... I've not had a lot of success with that one. It's too sporadic and uncontrollable."

"That's fine, you don't need to tell us anything else." Sasha said, holding up her palm. "I'll just tell you guys my power next."

She hesitated, then looked around the warehouse. She found a metal table nearby with some tools stacked on it, then she grabbed a wrench off its top.

"I... don't think my power is all that great." Sasha said. "But basically, I can do this."

She held the wrench up. A glowing light emerged from her hand for a moment. Suddenly, the wrench began to decay and rust at a rate visible to the naked eye. Then, it abruptly lost cohesion and fell apart, turning into sand within her grasp. The particles slipped between her fingers and fell to the ground in an ashy pile.

"Holy... what... what did you even do?" Marco gasped, looking at her with widened eyes. "You turned that wrench into smoke!"

"It seems as if you made it fall apart at the molecular level." Nadia said, her words proving insightful yet again. Her eyes flashed with metaphorical light. "The collapse ratio was most speediest at the upper and lower ends of the wrench, but the most thorough collapse in its molecular structure occurred on the parts your hand directly gripped."

Daisy shot Nadia another look of surprise. She always knew Nadia was smart, but her ability to intuit things bordered on the supernatural.

"Yeah, it's some sort of molecular-cohesion ability." Sasha said. "It's even a little more complex than what I just showed you. Watch."

She grabbed two more tools off the table. In her right hand, she held an extremely rusted steel pipe, and in her left, a tire iron in otherwise good condition.

After a few seconds, the tire iron rapidly began to rust, and then it fell apart into dust, just like the wrench from before.

But the steel pipe didn't fall apart. Instead, it became cleaner, sharper, and much more 'pristine' looking than before. It was as if she restored it back to the way it looked when it first rolled off the factory line.

"Molecular transference?!" Nadia exclaimed. "You transferred the properties of the higher quality tire iron to the much shabbier steel pipe, thus restoring it back to new. Am I right?"

"It's probably something like that." Sasha said slowly. "But this is all I can do. I'm useless otherwise. I never have any reason to turn things into dust, and I certainly don't want to accidentally hurt or kill someone, so I suppress my ability in social situations."

"It may have more uses than you expect." Nadia said. "We'll have to find new ways to use it later."

Daisy finally spoke the words she'd been desperately holding in. "Sasha's powers are indeed interesting, but I find *you* even more fascinating right now, Nadia. What is your power, exactly? Can you finally tell us?"

The frail and thin girl looked up at Daisy with a look of sadness. Then she looked at the ground.

"I can... understand things. But the price I pay is high. I bring my body to ruin every time I use my ability."

"Understand things." Daisy repeated, mulling her words over. "What do you mean by that?"

Nadia didn't reply. She rubbed her arm sheepishly, then averted her eyes way off to the side.

"I... I've been..." Nadia mumbled, before stopping.

"You've been what?" Sasha asked. "Nadia, are you okay? You can tell us. We won't get mad."

"I've been lying to all of you! To everyone!" Nadia suddenly shouted, making the other girls jump. "I cheated. I cheated through all of school! I couldn't keep up with anyone else unless I used my power, but using my power broke my body down, made my bones brittle... and that made it more and more painful for me to study, so I felt like I was in a miserable loop where the only way to progress was by continuing to sabotage myself..."

Nadia flopped to the ground. She crossed her legs under her skirt and sat on her butt with a dejected look on her face.

"My brain is special, okay? I can understand stuff just by looking at it and concentrating. It's how I understood Sasha's power. But even though Daisy healed my bones, I felt them weaken again. If I keep using my power, I'll just go right back to the way I was before. A 'smart' but useless cripple, suffering in agony. Day after day!"

"Oh, Nadia..." Sasha said gently. "No, you can't... you can't think like that. You're not useless. That power of yours sounds really useful! And since Daisy can heal you, that means she can nullify its downsides, right? It's certainly better than my ability to make things rusty or not-rusty!"

Daisy glanced at Sasha. She wasn't entirely certain Sasha's power was useless in the least, but for now, it was better to just try and make Nadia feel better.

"Sasha's right. Brain-based powers are really rare." Daisy said. "I only know of Solomon and Madam Mildred as being ancient Heroes with big brains. I'll heal you any time you need it, Nadia. You should just focus on making yourself smarter and smarter!"

Nadia still looked glum, but the encouragement from her friends brightened her day, even if only a little. "Thank you, everyone... I do feel there's more hope than before, with Daisy's healing abilities. I still feel afraid to use my powers... but maybe I can have a little more courage, moving forward."

"Heck yeah!" Marco chimed in. "Even if you think your power sucks, I guarantee my power is worse than ALL yours. It's seriously... *so* bad, guys..."

Daisy finally turned to look at Marco. He was the last one to reveal his power, and she was growing more curious by the minute.

"So?" Daisy asked. "How does yours work? What is it?"

Marco's demeanor grew pensive. He shuffled back a step or two.

"I... I don't know if I should use it. It's kinda scary. The thought of misusing it frightens me." Marco said.

"I'm here. If anyone gets hurt, even mortally wounded, I can bring them back from the brink of death." Daisy said. "No matter how scary it is, you have to be brave. Do we need to put some distance between us and you?"

"No, you should be safe..." Marco said hesitantly. "It's just... I've only used my power three times. The first time was an accident. The second time was a test. The third time was... a tragedy..."

He squeezed his left wrist with his right hand, massaging his veins with even greater hesitation than before. After a moment, he looked around the warehouse and found a pile of loose bricks sitting on a pallet.

"I'll... aim for that." Marco said, turning to face it.

The girls all looked at one another. They took a few steps back and watched the pallet of bricks even more intensely than Marco did.

Slowly, deliberately, Marco raised his right arm. He held out his hand.

He snapped his fingers.

The pallet of bricks vanished from the spot.

Daisy's eyes popped open. The other girls gasped.

Not only were the pallet and all the bricks gone, but there was a perfectly smooth hole where they had sat, sunken into the ground. It looked like a giant orb had landed in soft mud and been pulled out, leaving a depression behind.

Before the girls could utter a word, the pallet abruptly reappeared, perfectly filling the depression back in, and appearing exactly the same as it did before.

Exactly one second had passed from the moment he snapped his fingers, it disappeared, and it reappeared.

Question marks popped up over Daisy's head.

"Wha... what happened?" Daisy asked. "You deleted it from existence? Then brought it back?"

Marco shook his head wryly.

"I don't know, Daisy."

"You don't know?" She repeated.

"I've only snapped my fingers three times in my life." Marco replied. His tone was sullen and resentful. "The first time, I accidentally 'deleted' the wall of my bedroom. For a split-second, the ceiling started to sag like it was about to collapse on me, but then the walls reappeared inside of the collapsing... well, it held the structure up, barely. I had to evacuate my family and told them the ceiling just started sagging out of nowhere. I'm not sure if they believed me."

"The second time was different." Marco said. "A week later, I grew a little more confident. I went over to the park and tried 'snapping' a tree out of reality. I fucked up. I only erased part of the tree at its bottom, and the upper half fell down, nearly crushing me to death. It slammed into the ground just a few feet on my left... I'm lucky I survived."

"Oh." Daisy mumbled.

Marco had nearly killed his family, and then he had nearly killed himself. It was no wonder he was scared to use his power.

"What about the third time?" Sasha asked.

Marco's expression deflated even further. He sunk to the ground and sat down in a disheveled pile, not dissimilar to how Nadia looked just a few minutes earlier.

"That one was the worst." Marco said under his breath.

He was quiet for a moment.

"The neighbor's dog was always barking. Always heckling me when I walked past. It was a big dog. A German Shepherd."

He continued.

"One day, it got loose. Broke through the gate and charged at me. I got scared since I was only 13, walking home alone. I snapped my fingers and made the dog disappear, along with part of the ground it was standing on. A second later, the dog reappeared... and it was dead."

"Dead? Your power killed it?" Daisy asked.

She was suddenly a lot more interested in... *whatever* his ability was.

"Yeah. Extremely dead." Marco muttered. "It was just a dog, man. Scary at the time to a scrawny teenage 'me', but if anyone was at fault, it was the dog's owners. I shouldn't

have killed him, man. I shouldn't have done it..."

"You couldn't have known." Daisy said, walking over and sitting beside Marco. She squeezed his shoulder reassuringly. "You were only a kid. You tensed up. And in the end, it was an aggressive dog... what if it had attacked another kid and mauled them or something? You saved a life!"

"*Might* have saved a life..." Marco said glumly. "Anyway, this power is shit and I hate it! It's cursed. It causes only pain and death. It almost killed me, and my family, and it DID kill a dog. I feel sick to my stomach, just thinking about using it."

Daisy scratched her head. In that moment, she realized that she couldn't really empathize with Marco's thoughts. He was way more innocent than her. She'd killed tens of people already, and she was only 18 years old. It wasn't as if Marco had stomped a puppy to death in cold blood, but had merely defended himself in the only way he knew how when an aggressive dog attacked him. Despite this, he fully blamed himself and felt deep guilt over his actions.

"Look, Marco... this power of yours isn't a curse. I believe that all Heroic Manifestations have a purpose or can be put to good use. Since you haven't tested your power much, why don't we try figuring out how it works so you can put it to better use in the future?"

"I don't know if I can." Marco said, still unable to look her in the eyes. "I think about that poor dog all the time. What if I 'snap' somebody's kid? What if I accidentally collapse a building and kill its occupants? There's too many things that can go wrong."

He finally looked up at the warehouse's torn-apart ceiling, with its patchwork roof that allowed cold and snowy sunlight to shine down from above.

"I'm just... *afraid*, Daisy. What if all I'm good for is killing and causing harm? I'd much rather have a power like your healing magic. I could travel the world, heal the sick, save lives... but this power is just a curse."

At that moment, a loud male voice spoke up from behind Marco, causing all the teenagers to jump in alarm.

"NO. You are wrong. Your power is NOT a curse."

Daisy's heart jumped out of her chest. She quickly stood up and turned around, where she saw a familiar man standing only two arms-lengths away.

"Dad?!" Daisy exclaimed. "You're here? Why are you here?"

And why can't I read your thoughts? Daisy wondered, as she stared at the man before her.

Jason Hiro stood casually, as if materializing inside a warehouse out of nowhere was not even a matter worth discussing. He smiled at the teenagers one by one before fixing his gaze on his daughter.

"Hey, Daisy. Long time, no see. I suddenly felt like I was missing you, so I wanted to find out how you were doing. So I came here. And look at what I found... you have super-powered friends! And each one has an extremely unique and useful ability!"

Marco had already jumped to his feet. He stood a few feet behind Daisy and looked at the 'man' standing before him.

"Uhh... this guy is your... father?" Marco asked. "He looks maybe 20 years old, if that."

"I can change my body's appearance if I want. I just don't feel like doing so right now." Jason said. "Marco, Nadia, Sasha. It's good to meet all of you. I am Jason Hiro, the... Archseer."

He paused, then slightly cocked his head.

"Say... it's the weekend now. How would you kids like to take a little field trip and see something Daisy's old man cooked up, eh?"

He grinned.

"You think your parents would be cool with you disappearing for a day or two?"

Marco's expression brightened. "My dad won't mind. I'll have to call my mom and let her know, though."

"I can just tell my daddy I need to take a business trip. He never minds as long as I bring a couple bodyguards." Sasha replied.

"There won't be any problems on my end." Nadia concluded.

With their answers given, Jason nodded. "Alright. I'll let you guys make your calls, and then we'll be off."

Daisy stared at Jason. "And where are you taking us, dad? Some new secret base of yours?"

Jason's grin widened even further.

"Oh, honey, my new spot is... *out of this world!*"

Part 665: Nadia's Body-Brain Drain

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Jason, Daisy, Marco, Sasha, and Nadia all appeared inside the center of Argent City, brought there by Jason's Wordsmithing. Upon their arrival, the four teenagers gasped with shock, then became more and more amazed by the sights they beheld.

It had only been a few more months inside Aevum since Jason brought his father there, but already he had developed the world further, and now it was really starting to come alive.

After Sir Marcus the Parakeet had gone back and told all the other animals about Aevum, they collectively decided to travel to Aevum and live there together. Now, all of Harold's animal friends, as well as Harold himself, had taken up residence inside Argent City. The teenagers were shocked to find that talking animals greeted them on arrival, while Harold himself had been granted a small house not too far from the city center, where he was also given a view of the city through a large window. He could peep out and watch the world change as he desired, and this brought the old man more interesting views than he had been accustomed to over the decades.

"Greetings, child of Jason." Sir Marcus said, perched atop Jason's shoulder. He bowed his head at Daisy. "I have long heard tale of your illustrious name. Miss Daisy is as beautiful as her father claimed! The rest of you must be the young lady's companions!"

"What a polite and well-spoken parrot!" Sasha said in amazement.

"Ah, I am a member of the Parrot branch, but I am specifically a parakeet, my dear." Marcus said demurely. He puffed his feathers up. "Please mind your words and be accurate when using terminology, lest others take offense."

Sasha blinked twice. "I... see. Sorry."

Jason took the teenagers up into the sky via his magical flying rowboat. Sometimes they marveled at the towering spires of energy, and other times at the hovering orbs and cubes and triangular machines in the skies above. The magical leylines had become less brilliant as they blended more tightly into Argent City's soil drew less prominent cries, but Daisy still paid attention to them and pondered on their significance.

Eventually, Jason brought the group over to the eastern side of the city, where he had built a heavily reinforced underground bunker out of pure Wordsmithium.

"So. It seems you three have obtained powers, but you don't know how they work. We're going to get to the bottom of this mystery today."

"But how?" Marco asked. "My power is dangerous... I don't want to hurt anyone."

Jason snorted. He gave Marco a sardonic smile. "Dangerous is exactly what we need right now. If you knew how much threat humanity was under, you wouldn't be so hesitant to master your powers. But don't worry, I get how you feel. I was a lot like you when I was a kid. I made a lot of mistakes as a result of not pushing my abilities to the max."

Marco glanced at Sasha. She sent a raised eyebrow back at him.

Jason barely looked twenty. Why was he talking like some old man? Sasha even thought he looked somewhat attractive, with a decently well-toned but rather scrawny body. If he worked out more, he could be a total hunk!

What was even more bizarre was the revelation that he was Daisy's father! How did that even work??

As Jason's magical boat landed on the brick steps outside the underground bunker, Jason turned to the others.

"Aevum is a special dimension. It is not located on Earth. It is located inside a folded space, far from the Sol system. Time flows differently here. One Earth day translates to one Aevum year. That means if you kids spend an entire year mastering your powers in here, by the time you leave, it will only be Saturday back in Russia. Therefore, since you've told your families you were going to leave for the weekend, I'll be having you spend two years mastering your powers and their nuances here. You'll be back home by Monday, Earth-time."

Sasha's eyes metaphorically popped out of her head. "Whoa-whoa-whoa!! Two years?? That's crazy! I can't afford to spend two years of my life on this! I... I have hobbies! Things I like to do! What about hanging with my friends, going to the mall, all that other stuff?!"

"You're with your friends now, aren't you?" Jason asked, a question mark seemingly popping up over his head. "And don't worry. I'll make all of you immortal, so you won't actually be losing years of your life or anything."

This time, it was Marco who became shocked. "Did you just say IMMORTAL?! How the hell- who even are you?!"

"I'm Jason Hiro." Jason replied calmly. "Daisy's father. Also known as... the Archseer!"

Daisy looked at her dad in confusion.

The Archseer? But wasn't his title the Wordsmith?

Jason winked at his daughter. She tactfully decided not to question his motivations right now.

"I possess all sort of incredible powers." Jason said casually. "You'll find out about them as you live here. Just treat this like a time-accelerated vacation where you get to live without growing up for a year or two. It's going to be a lot of fun, kids."

They all entered the bunker and took the elevator downward, where they arrived inside a training facility.

There, the teens found a well-equipped bunker with food dispensers that could last for decades, training dummies made of many different materials, animals in cages meant for testing powers, and even a whole host of firearms along with a shooting range. Just in case.

"I built this just for you guys, based on what I could glean from what you showed and told Daisy about." Jason explained. "I intend to get to the bottom of each one of your abilities before I send you three home."

"You were spying on us?" Nadia asked, looking at Jason suspiciously.

"Yup." Jason said, shooting her a grin. "I spy on lots of different people, all the time. Since you guys hang out with my daughter, I have to be extra careful."

Daisy gave her father a strange look, but she ultimately said nothing. She felt a little uncomfortable by his revelation, but also a little warm and fuzzy inside. It was good to know her father cared so much, but the privacy boundaries he was pushing had to be discussed later when they had some time alone together.

"Nadia. Let's start with you." Jason said. "You seem to possess some sort of brain-enhancing power that comes at the cost of your body's integrity. Specifically... your bones?"

"It's usually my bones." Nadia said with a small nod. "When I use my power... I can understand things very easily. But not long after, there's a terrible spike of pain, and I feel dizzy, and that's about when my body weakens..."

"Alright. Can you show me?" Jason asked. "Don't worry. Daisy and I can both heal any injuries your body suffers."

Nadia looked hesitant, but she eventually nodded. "I've been using my ability a lot over the years. If you've already restored my bones back to their peak, then I can use my power a lot before I become as weakened as I was previously."

Her eyes momentarily flashed with blue light. She glanced around the room, then she stopped to think.

"The alloy comprising this room's walls is not what it first appears to be. It is not steel, titanium, or comprised of any other known metal. It appears to be an enhanced alloy far stronger than anything currently obtainable on Earth."

She walked over to the wall, picked up a metal pipe on the ground, and swung it at the wall with a good deal of her strength. The wall did not make a loud, metallic clanging noise when the pipe struck, but instead was eerily quiet, as if it was made of rubber. Nadia set the pipe down.

"This alloy defies the known laws of physics. If I had to hazard a guess, I would assume you used your magic to heavily reinforce it beyond the limits of what mundane technology can create. I'm willing to wager that even a diamond-tipped drill would not be able to bore a small hole into this alloy."

Jason raised his eyebrows. "That was an excellent bit of deductive reasoning."

"I can do a lot more than that." Nadia said. "I usually limited myself to lightly cheating on homework, but I found my power can accomplish other things as well."

With that, Nadia looked around the room. She walked over to a training dummy, then suddenly scared the daylights out of Daisy and the others when she began executing a punching routine on the dummy that was anything but amateur!

Thunk-thunk, crack, thunk-thump-THUMP!

Nadia drove her fists into the dummy's center, spun agilely on her heel to hit the dummy's 'ribs' with her leg, and even snapped a kick all the way up at its head!

In a single barrage, she struck the dummy twelve times, making Daisy's jaw drop.

"You... how are you able to fight so well??" Daisy asked in bewilderment.

"Her power is 'comprehension.'" Jason said, his tone one of astonishment. "She doesn't just learn about things, she comprehends them. If I read a book about bird species, I might learn a bit about their feather colors and some other stuff, but Nadia would fully comprehend the information and become a master of its contents."

Jason raised a finger. "Nadia, did you watch a martial arts competition and learn from it using your powers?"

"Just some old Kung Fu movies." Nadia said. "My comprehension is good, but my body is weak. I just wanted to see if I could learn a little self-defense, but when I learned about the condition of my body, I gave all that up. Now I'm starting to think I might be able to learn how to fight again."

Jason smiled. He grabbed a bo staff off a nearby display and tossed it to her. "Ever used one of these before?"

Nadia shook her head. She gripped the staff by its center, but Jason could tell with a single glance that she was a complete amateur.

"Perfect. This will give us a barometer for your future potential."

Jason summoned his own bo staff into his hands.

"I want you to learn from me. Watch my movements carefully."

He then began revolving his weapon around his body at extremely fast speeds. The staff spun and twisted like a hurricane of wood, revolving from his right side to his left with practiced ease. Nadia's eyes glowed as she watched, and after thirty seconds, Jason stopped.

"Okay. Your turn." Jason said.

Nadia nodded. Daisy, Marco, and Sasha all gasped in excitement when the visibly clumsy Nadia from less than a minute before vanished, and in her place a seasoned bo-staff expert appeared. Nadia spun the staff around her body with nearly the same ease as Jason, though it was clear that her smaller size and weaker muscles had not practiced at all, and she was still not at his level.

Then, Nadia suddenly screamed in pain. The staff flew from her hands and clattered to the floor as she fell to the ground, grabbing her ribs and crying out.

"Aaah!!"

Daisy's heart jumped. She ran over to Nadia and realized she had fractured a rib during her staff theatrics. Watching Jason intensely practice for thirty seconds had apparently weakened her bones to such a level that she was able to badly injure herself.

Daisy summoned healing magic and repaired Nadia's bones, but she realized that she was not able to fully heal her, or strengthen her 'frame' in any noticeable way. For some reason, her healing powers were less effective than the last time she used them on Nadia.

"Your power is amazing. It's incredible." Jason said, lightly touching Nadia's shoulder as he knelt beside her. "I can heal the injuries your power caused, but fundamentally, the drawback of your power needs to be fully countered. The reason you have to deal with such vicious drawbacks is because your power is absurdly strong."

"It is?" Nadia asked, looking at Jason doubtfully. The pain in her ribs made breathing difficult, but she still chose to listen to his words carefully.

"Absolutely I know of a... *person*. His name is Zamiel-"

"That's a really strange name." Nadia immediately interjected.

"-and Zamiel has the ability to immediately comprehend how to use any weapon he touches. I thought this power was good, but yours blows it way out of the water! You seem to be able to comprehend *anything* you put your mind on. The problem is, it puts a huge strain on your brain, which in turn draws the vitality it needs from your bones and marrow."

Nadia's gaze darkened. "It does sound incredible when you describe my power that way... but the price..."

"Is nothing to worry about at all!" Jason chirped excitedly. He beamed a huge smile at the teenager, then he waved his hand, causing a wristband to materialize in his grasp. It had a set of obnoxiously large and colorful jewels embedded into the band with one-centimeter gaps between them. They seemed to represent different colors of the rainbow, and there were seven of them in total.

"What is that?" Nadia asked, eyeing the band with interest.

"A little stopgap solution I whipped up." Jason explained casually. This is a rechargeable Vitality Band. While you are in Aevum, as long as you wear this band, you should be able to use your powers just about as often as you need. It will passively heal

your bones and regenerate your vitality by absorbing the rich ambient mana and life energy present in Aevum. Once you leave Aevum and return to Earth... it will *still* work, but the recharging time will be much longer and you'll only be able to use your abilities a few times a day, injuring yourself if the band runs out of power when you activate your magic."

Jason magically teleported the band onto Nadia's wrist without speaking a Word of Power, making Daisy narrow her eyes with suspicion. She suddenly realized he hadn't uttered a single Word of Power since she arrived, and he had made that band seemingly on the spot. How did he do it? Had he found a way to evolve his abilities?

After the band clamped onto Nadia's wrist, her body abruptly filled with vigor. She took a deep breath, and her rib stopped hurting. After a moment or two, she stood up and looked at her palms in shock. She didn't just feel normal, she felt positively energized! It seemed as if she could study night and day for the next several weeks without needing any sleep!

"Like I mentioned," Jason said, noticing the look of excitement on Nadia's face, "this is only a stopgap solution. I'll engineer a better one before you leave Aevum. We have two years, after all, and I can get a lot accomplished in that time. Before you leave here, I want to make sure you can freely use your power as often as you wish."

Nadia smiled gratefully. "Thank you, Jason. Daisy said you were an amazing man... I see now that her praise didn't go far enough."

Jason returned the smile, but after a moment, that smile disappeared.

"You might think I'm great, but I often remember my past failings. I've screwed up a lot to reach the mental state I'm at now. Let's hope the rest of you don't have to suffer the same pain I have."

Jason glanced at his daughter.

"Your friends are powerful, Daisy. Much more powerful than the Lowborn I've seen before. I'm starting to wonder if they aren't just Lowborn at this point, but a new breed of Trueborn Heroes."

Daisy blinked. "Huh? Lowborn? Trueborn? Dad, what are you talking about?"

Jason blinked back. "What do YOU mean, 'what do I mean'? I told you about Lowborn and Trueborn, didn't I? About the Human Flaw?"

Daisy and Jason stared at each other with stupid expressions for three long seconds.

"Dad... you never said anything of the sort." Daisy complained. "What 'Flaw'? What's this about?"

Jason suddenly remembered... he hadn't discovered the Flaw until well after Daisy's supposed death. He hadn't learned about Trueborn and Lowborn until well after she'd time-traveled either. And when he first spoke to her in Idaho, he didn't think to mention them because he assumed she would have known already!

"Wow, sorry honey." Jason said, scratching his head awkwardly. "Well, since I have you all here, I might as well explain the Flaw."

And so he did.

"It all started tens of thousands of years ago, when the angels first created humanity-" Jason started to say.

"Angels??" Sasha asked. "Whoa whoa, I didn't take you for the religious type. Are you about to start quoting scripture at us?"

"No..." Jason said slowly. "I'm not talking about ancient myths. Angels are real. And I guess that means if you don't know about them, you don't know about demons either-"

"Demons and angels are REAL?!" Marco shrieked in horror. "No way! No goddamn way!"

Jason sighed. This was going to be a longer conversation that he anticipated.

* * *

Six full hours later, after giving everyone, including his daughter, the abridged story of humanity, the war against the demons and angels, and even the future threat of the Volgrim, Jason started to feel quite tired.

"Your father is from the future... and so are you. Holy hell, Daisy." Sasha said, gaping at her 'best friend' in disbelief. She truly knew nothing about who Daisy really was!

"I barely remember the time I came from." Daisy said sullenly. "I remember my mom's face. I remember my Uncle Kar. Aunt Samantha. Other bits and pieces. But the big picture is a blur."

"Let's get back to where we were before." Jason said, after finally remembering what the original discussion was. "The fact that all your closest friends have become Heroes

means that their Flaws have been healed. You may have passively empowered them by being in their vicinity all these years."

Daisy nodded slowly. "That... kinda makes sense."

"It's a normal phenomenon." Jason explained. "Apparently, whenever Heroes have existed in the past, certain people close to them have somewhat healed their Flaws. Though, that begs the question of whether your uncle and other Russian relatives have also secretly obtained powers. We'll need to check to see if they have."

Daisy frowned. It seemed very unlikely her Uncle Vasily had obtained powers, but what about her little sister Anya? Had she, perhaps?

"Daisy, you've been teleporting all over the Earth for years, right?" Jason asked.

Daisy nodded. "Yes. Why do you ask?"

"Because my dad, your grandfather, he told me that recently, after all his rewinding escapades, humans with powers suddenly started appearing en-masse. It's likely this was your doing. You may not only be repairing the Human Flaw, but empowering people beyond their ordinary limits. That's why I'm saying each of your friends has the power of a Trueborn. It's unprecedented!"

"Not to be rude," Daisy said, "and not to diminish the awesomeness of their powers, but each of them only seems to have one power, whereas you and I have multiple. Doesn't that make them... lesser Heroes? Lowborn, or whatever?"

"By no means." Jason said with a smile. "It's like Bruce Lee said. Don't fear the man who has practiced 1000 kicks one time each, but the man who has practiced one kick 1000 times. Your friends are Specialists, while you and I are generalists. Specialists may only have one or two powers, but their powers are usually much stronger than the abilities of Generalists with similar powers. Take Nadia, for example. Her power is similar to Zamiel's, yet far broader and more potent."

"Hey." Nadia said suddenly. "Zamiel really *is* a weird name. Is he an angel? Or maybe a demon?"

"Demon." Jason replied. "And a real trashbag of one, too. I hope you never run into him."

Jason returned to the previous topic at hand. "If you're only healing the Flaw, then that's one thing. But if you're also somehow supercharging the spirituality of some people,

that's a whole different ballgame. Even I never figured out how to do that. I probably will someday, but it's still amazing you might possess the ability innately!"

Sasha looked skeptical. "Nadia's power is awesome and all, but mine seems pretty weak. Marco thinks his isn't any good either. Don't you think you're jumping the gun a little bit, Mister Hiro?"

Jason waggled a finger at Sasha before turning to smile at her. "We have not gotten to yours and Marco's yet. Let's not jump to conclusions, alright? I have a feeling that neither of you have even scratched the surface of what is possible."

Jason straightened his posture and crossed his arms.

"You will have two years inside Aevum to master your abilities. By the time you leave here, you should have grown to at least understand some of the finer nuances of what you can do, even if you haven't become elite warriors or anything crazy like that. Along the way, I'm going to be bringing other Lowborn into Aevum, and I plan to come up with a solution to secretly purify the Flaw across all of humanity at once. That's when things are going to speed up dramatically in the future wars humanity will fight."

"Are wars... really necessary?" Marco asked with great hesitation.

"War is inevitable." Jason answered solemnly. "It cannot be stopped. Not even by me."

Part 666: HELL ON EARTH

January 29th, 2021. Eastern Egypt.

In a sand-covered land of dunes and mountains, no place in particular stood out much. Humanity, for the most part, remained oblivious to the ancient secrets hidden within Egypt's borders.

South of Israel, between the Gulf of Suez and the Gulf of Agaba, at a point directly between those two bodies of water, there stood a small cathedral and tourist exhibit. Guests from all across Egypt and other neighboring countries would sometimes come to see the sights of the untamed wilderness, and to pay their respect to the ancient figure whose image was enshrined inside its walls.

This region was known as Saint Catherine's Monastery, and its holy site was ordained thousands of years earlier by the forces of righteousness whose names were not widely distributed among those not in the know.

With a population of 4,600, Saint Catherine's Monastery was quite sizable for a desertified town. It was built at the foot of Mount Sinai, and only the most privileged members of humanity knew the truth about this seemingly insignificant but culturally historical summit.

It was the location of the entrance to *Heaven*.

Heavily guarded, hidden by multiple high-level illusion formations and defensive wards, it was one of the most fortified locations on the Earth. Even a nuclear bomb sent flying at the mountain would only be able to detonate a mile above it, when it struck a barrier of divine energy laid down millennia prior by Archangel Camael and her other allies.

Even if the mountain itself was destroyed, it would be no issue for the angels. In truth, they had secretly constructed other entrances to Heaven elsewhere on Earth, but these entrances were considered backups and never used for anything more than dispatching angels in disguise. The primary entrance on Sinai was where 99% of all angels entered and departed, god-willing.

Saint Catherine's Monastery accomplished many strategic objectives for the angels. It was an unimportant backwater pilgrimage site where only the most devout Christians visited, and it was not particularly impressive. It was also where the ashen remains of Saint Catherine, the legendary Valkyrie who killed Demon Emperor Valac, had been laid to rest. Her noble sacrifice had eventually been memorialized eternally by naming an entire city after her. Her sword, the Sword from Heaven, had gone on to land in the hands of the Trueborn Hero, Joan of Arc.

Over time, the humans who took up residence at Saint Catherine's Monastery had invented all sorts of superstitious takes on who 'Catherine' really was. The idea that she was truly an angel never entered anyone's mind. Naturally, that had been a part of the original mythos, but most people assumed those were merely ancient people not knowing their heads from their feet. She had slowly become a human figure of myth, and then her original legend had faded out of memory.

It was on this day that the chief priest at the Monastery stepped onto the podium before a congregation of four hundred devotees. He wore simple white ceremonial robes, and his thin figure made him appear docile and unremarkable. Even so, he had a divine light in his eyes. He was one of only a handful of people who knew the actual truth of the Monastery. This Truth had been passed down from one Monastery Head to the next for thousands of years.

"Brothers, sisters, and newcomers alike. I am Father Lou." The old man said. "Every Friday, we pray to the graven image of Jesus in respect of the ancestors, and we allow a voice among the flock to speak his or her insight into the scriptures. Today, our guest speaker is a pilgrim from the west; the capital city of Cairo. It is not often we have someone from the Great City here, and while his credentials are rather modest, I pray that you will all give him a warm welcome."

Father Lou gestured to the left. A dark-skinned man with an even leaner build than Lou himself slowly stepped onto the stage. He was completely unremarkable. His teeth were chipped. His hair was clean, but it seemed to only be an action he had performed for this particular occasion. The buildup of debris on his face made it quite evident that showers and baths were not a luxury he partook in often.

"This is Brother Clarence." Father Lou explained. "He is a homeless wanderer who has suffered a hard life. When he told me his story, I wept countless tears alongside him.

Despite the hand he was dealt, I became inspired by his tale, and invited him to speak today. Brother Clarence, why don't you lead the flock today in prayer?"

Clarence shuffled forward. He bowed his head humbly and smiled at Father Lou.

"Father, thank you for your generosity. It has been many a moon since I experienced such warm love and devotion from my fellow man. The capital city is overrun by men with materialism in their hearts, and women who have fallen into the throes of lust. It is good to know that men and women who walk with God still lay claim to some of Earth's lands."

Father Lou stepped aside, making room at the podium for Clarence after they kissed one another on the cheek. Then Clarence took a moment to collect his thoughts.

"Before I begin, let us all offer a short moment of silence to the image of Christ." Clarence said.

Everyone in the room followed his guidance. They closed their eyes, pressed their palms together, and bowed their heads. After a few moments, they took their seats and awaited Clarence's next words.

"Brothers and sister. Mothers and fathers. Sons and daughters." Clarence said, taking care to speak loudly and project his voice to even the furthest pews. "The world we have been born into is not the same world as the one in which our parents lived, and that world was equally different from the ones of their parents, and their parents' parents, and so on. Every day, I feel that humanity's love unravels, bit by bit, more and more."

"Always," he continued, "there are good men and women out there. But the ease in which communities have degraded fills my heart with shame. Humans are destroying the planet. We are losing our love not only for one another, but for the plants, trees, bugs and animals that share this beautiful world with us."

Several people nodded. There were many among the flock who were foreigners who had moved to the monastery to live a more modest life, abandoning their materialistic ways, but far more of them were native residents who had only heard of the greed and decadence of distant powers secondhand and thirdhand from others. They had not seen such horrors with their own eyes, but they 'knew' what Brother Clarence was saying must be true!

"Every day, I pray to the Lord regarding how He plans to save our world." Clarence continued. "And recently, when I was praying, I suddenly heard His voice speak back to

me! His angels had heard my prayers! The Lord knows that humanity has become too corrupted by its decadence. It has strayed too far from its origin. Our species has mutated into a disease upon His beloved blue Earth. We rape the oceans, burn the forests, and murder the wildlife, all to satiate our own greed! Surely, there must be a better way? Surely, there must be something we can do to stymie the bleeding and begin rebuilding for the betterment of all species?"

Clarence paused. His eyes flickered around as he looked at several audience members randomly, making them feel as if he were speaking to them personally.

On the sidelines, Father Lou watched Clarence's speech with rapt attention. His heart swelled with awe as he realized this Clarence might initially seem simple and unassuming, but in reality, he had an incredible knack for public speaking! Every word incited the audience's interest and sucked them deeper into his flow. Even Father Lou was becoming greatly invested in what Clarence would say next.

This was not a talent that could easily be trained. It had to be granted by the Divines at birth!

Clarence was no ordinary man. He was blessed by the Angels! And only Lou knew the Truth of this matter based on his lifetime of knowledge and access to information. He would surely alert the Angels as to Clarence's gift, following his sermon.

"We must return to our roots. We must aggressively spread the Gospel of Christ!" Clarence declared. "We must return to the womb from whence we came and be reborn anew, ready to show our fellow humans that there is a better path forward!"

Clarence's fiery words slowly died down in intensity. He shook his head and revealed a sad expression.

"Unfortunately... I am but one man. I am a humble vagrant. A traveler with no home of my own, and no family to love me. I can speak my Truths, but I cannot spread His message across the Earth. Only with the help of other like-minded people can the love of Christ reach the ears of even the most hard-hearted listeners abroad! So that is why I have come here today. I wish to ask all of you... are you willing to abandon your home, join me, and spread the Word of the Divines?!"

Clarence raised his voice.

"Are you?!"

The audience didn't reply at first. They were so captivated by his words that their souls nearly left their bodies. After a few moments, most of the audience members stood up and raised their fists.

"We are ready!" A man exclaimed.

"I wish to spread Jesus's love!" A woman shouted.

"Sitting here will accomplish nothing. We must be proactive!" Another man added.

One by one, the people in the audience threw their metaphorical hats into the ring. Clarence beamed a smile at all of them.

"Brothers. Sisters. You are not wrong to believe in my vision! Some believe that the Lord giveth, and the Lord taketh away. But I disagree! We cannot expect Him to do all the work! We must serve Him and give Him the fruits of our labor as proof of our devotion! It is God's job to punish, but our job to send the sinners to meet him!"

Clarence's last comment caused a strange expression to pass over Father Lou's face, but that moment passed. He dismissed it as Clarence simply being a little too excited in the passion of his speech.

"Well spoken, Brother Clarence!" Father Lou said. "It is true that often man is weak and fickle of mind, too absorbed in himself to give back to the Lord. You have brought an important matter to all our attention!"

"Thank you, Father." Clarence said, his tone becoming a bit more humble as he bowed back toward Lou. "Of course, it is not enough to merely speak empty words. To that end, I would like to continue today's lesson by reading some key verses from the books of Matthew and John. As I was reading them, I noticed some passages that would even enlighten those of us with open minds toward the Lord's will! Take for example-"

He turned to speak to the audience once more, but at that moment, the front doors to the monastery were flung open. An old monk rushed inside, panic on his face.

"Father Lou! Father Lou!!"

Lou frowned. It was out of the ordinary for Brother Tamas to interrupt a Friday service.

"What is the matter?" Lou asked.

"Monsters! Horrible monsters! They're approaching the monastery from the west!!" Brother Tamas half-screamed. "Horrible creatures with red skin and long horns on their heads! They look like humans, but they are bloodthirsty and wretched! They will fall upon us within minutes!!"

"Demons." Father Lou whispered in horror, his eyes shrinking to pinpricks. "S-stay calm! Everyone, the ancestors knew a Day of Sin would befall the non-believers! Quickly, come to the altar! We must all place our hands upon Catherine's Table and beseech her and the Divines to save the monastery!"

Brother Clarence looked around in utter confusion. As a guest, he was not aware of what was going on, but the regulars of the church moved quickly and without panicking. They followed Father Lou's orders and moved toward the altar atop the Holy Pedestal. One by one, they all placed a hand upon it and began to chant according to Lou's instructions.

"Ancient ones! Servants of the Divine! We beseech you! Save us from the Red Calamity!"

Their minuscule amounts of mana barely served to ignite the altar's hidden function. A flicker of light appeared in the air, a mere ball of energy, which then launched into the sky and passed through the roof harmlessly.

Outside the monastery, the screams of people began to grow louder and louder. Those shrieks of horror escalated in intensity. Some of them cut off abruptly, followed by distant, wicked peals of laughter that drew nearer and nearer.

Brother Tamas shut the large wooden doors of the monastery. He swung a heavy metal bar down to lock the entrance tightly, then looked at Father Lou with a face drained of blood.

"What now?!" Tamas asked.

"The ritual is complete!" Lou exclaimed. "Everyone, help me push the altar aside. There is a secret passage leading underground. Brother Clarence, you should take the devotees and flee with them to the east! I will stay here to act as a distraction to these hellish invaders!"

"Father Lou!" Tamas cried. "No, you can't stay! Those monsters will kill you!"

"If the monastery is empty, they will grow suspicious and follow you." Lou said solemnly. "Now... GO! Do not delay another moment!"

And so they did. Clarence was the first to enter, taking up a torch and lighting it before descending into the passage beneath the altar. Hundreds of people quickly followed after him, single-file, leaving only Father Lou behind.

Lou used all of his strength to heave the altar back into place. He dislocated his shoulder from the strain, but luckily he managed to put the altar perfectly back into place before crawling away and collapsing in exhaustion at the bottom of the steps.

"Demon... bastards..." Lou grieved, listening to the sounds of innocent people falling like wheat to the chaff outside the monastery's doors.

Not even a minute later, the door exploded! Heavy chunks of wood, along with the large steel bar, flew across the room and slammed against the monastery's far walls.

A powerful demon with the aura of a Baron strode inside and looked around. Two other Barons followed behind him.

"The Monastery is empty." The lead Baron said, looking at father Lou's collapsed figure shivering on the ground. "Save for this one fellow."

"I recognize him." A female Baron said. "He's the head of the monastery; Father Lou. The intelligence said he leads a service on Fridays. He must have helped the others escape."

Father Lou raised his head to look up at the three demons in horror. He didn't recognize them, but he knew they could kill him with a flick of their wrists.

Most frighteningly, they saw right through his plan to save the others. Clarence was in danger, along with the rest of the flock! There was no way they could outrun this blood-hungry horde of demons!

Luckily, the lead Baron's next words dissipated his greatest fear.

"It doesn't matter. We're not here to kill a few lousy humans. Let them go. Start fortifying this location for the main assault force. We won't have long before the angels respond."

The lead Baron casually walked over to Father Lou. He looked down at the human with disinterest.

"I am Hamir, the Baron of Frost. How does it feel, knowing your life is about to end, little human?"

Lou gritted his teeth. "I have lived... a long life! I do not fear death! The Divines will punish you, hellspawn!"

"Ah. So you're one of those types." Hamir said with a light eye-roll. "Always fun to converse with."

He waved his hand, and a blistering cold wave swept over Father Lou, flash-freezing his body and blood, turning him into a thousand icicles and exploding his figure from the inside-out. He didn't even feel any pain as his frozen body parts were sent scattering all across the tiled floor of the church.

"Vepar is already setting down the poison traps." The female Baron, Vespera, said. Her blackened, shadowy figure flickered as daylight passed through her body. "The Emperors should arrive within an hour or two, once they've amassed their strength. Then, we'll begin the assault on Heaven's Gate."

"What about the rumors of the two Heroes?" Hamir asked. "Are they credible? Two Trueborn in the same generation?"

"It's never happened before, but you know the humans." Vespera said. "They have a knack for surprises."

"Very true." Hamir concluded.

He and the other two Barons split up. They joined the rest of the assault force, sweeping away all the humans in the city through a rapid and violent slaughter-session. Thousands of pilgrims and acolytes screamed one last time before their bodies were ripped apart, flash-frozen, burned to ashes, or crushed into piles of meat and bone.

The humans stood no chance. This was only a backwater monastery, not a place with any formidable military force.

"Baron Hamir!" A Demon Lord shouted, running toward Hamir with great haste. "We detected a trace of holy energy traveling out of the monastery toward Mount Sinai. It's likely the humans managed to alert the damned *pigeons*."

"We expected as much. There's no way the angels would allow themselves to be caught unawares again." Hamir said, unperturbed. "We'll just have to work faster. Everyone, be on your guard. The enemy could swoop down from above at any time. They hold an

undeniable aerial advantage against us. Don't let yourselves get picked off without a fight!"

Hamir wasn't worried. He may not have fought during the War in Heaven, but he had heard stories. The angels lost 99% of their pureblooded fighting forces. The replacements were paltry weaklings by comparison.

What did the demons have to fear from a bunch of resurrected humans? The Lazarites were only a threat in the sense of their vast numerical forces. Individually, they were only as strong as Demon Grunts and occasionally Demon Lords. Even if a hundred Lazarites came at Hamir all together, he could slaughter them with ease.

"Enemies spotted in the northwestern skies!" A demon suddenly called out. "They're swooping around. They have halos over their heads... and they're wielding bows! They're Lazarites!"

Hamir's mind engaged at full gear. He spun to look around and easily spotted five angels flying in a wide arc across the skies. As they flew, they notched arrows in their magical bows and fired downward, killing one or two random demon grunts. Nobody truly worth noting.

"Those are only the initial scouts!" Hamir exclaimed. "Take them out so they can't join with the reinforcements later!"

After delivering his command, a rain of fireballs flew into the skies, tracking the angel's movements. The armored fliers took a couple hits, but their enchanted platemail rainments absorbed and deflected all the damage, so they didn't suffer any serious injuries. At the same time, more arrows of light sailed downward and speared another handful of demons.

Multiple volleys flew into and from the air. The demons failed to kill any of the angel scouts, but the angels only succeeded in killing off more than twenty Grunts. Considering how utterly disposable such weak demons were, nobody shed any tears for them except their brood-siblings.

For some reason, one of the angels broke away from the other four. This lone brave warrior picked out the auras of all the high-level demons in the initial assault force and swooped toward a distant Baron hidden behind a building.

Hamir frowned. Before he could call out a warning, the angel disappeared from view... and that Baron's mana signature abruptly cut off.

"What?!" Hamir gasped in shock. "Dead? How could Baron Aramir die? Did it only take the enemy a single hit? But these are mere Lazarites!"

The lone angel warrior leaped back up into the air, spinning with practiced ease as he dodged multiple volleys of fireballs and earth lances flung at him from below.

Then, his attention focused on Hamir. The Baron of Frost felt a shudder go down his spine as the angel flapped his wings, took to the skies, and swooped toward him. He almost felt as if a ferocious predator had locked onto him with its cold, hungry eyes.

"Shit! This Lazarite isn't like the others! His movements are much more fluid! He must be one of the ancient Lazarites, hundreds of years old!" Hamir shouted.

There was always a combat quality difference when it came to the ages of Lazarites. The longer they lived, the more time their human intellect had to experiment with their powers, master their flying speeds, and grow more practiced in the art of war.

But even so, this particular Lazarite was way above his four peers. Their armor had some scorch marks from fireballs, but his didn't at all!

His? Hamir thought, as he noticed the long white hair trailing from behind the Lazarite. *No, this elite is a woman! But who?*

The female Lazarite pulled out a glowing golden spear. She flew directly at Hamir, aiming to spear his heart in one strike. Without hesitation, he exploded a cloud of white frost around himself, obscuring his surroundings and hiding his aura. Then he dove to the right and formed a shield of ice just in the nick of time.

CRAAAAACK!!!

The spear had somehow managed to track his position, the Lazarite only failing to kill him like she did Baron Aramir due to his hastily conjured ice wall. She broke through the wall and skidded to a stop behind Hamir, who quickly spun on his heel to fire a gust of icy wind at her.

What he saw made his heart turn frigid. The Lazarite woman immediately transformed her spear into a massive tower shield, deflected his wind, then flapped her wings and rushed at Hamir before he could react. She slammed into him with the shield

and sent him flying through the wall of a nearby building, causing it to partially collapse atop him.

Hamir's teeth chattered with fear.

It's her! Spawn of a- it's the Daughter of Heaven!!

The woman's face may have been hidden by her helmet, but her martial prowess was already becoming feared by the demons. Some said she had the makings of a Valkyrie. Others claimed she was above them. A tentative minority even believed she had the makings of a future Archangel.

The building exploded as Hamir unleashed all his demonic power, sending chunks of stone and wood flying in all directions. He roared hatefully at Heaven's Child.

"I don't fear you! Pigeon BITCH! Your story will end here, at my hands!"

The Daughter of Heaven looked at him, her expression hidden beneath her helmet.

"You may think me the fiercest opponent you've ever faced, but I shall not remember your face by day's end." She said, her tone one of utter disinterest.

She was Cassiel, the Daughter of Heaven.

The Mightiest Lazarite.

Part 667: Hellspawn vs Heavenspawn

Recommended Listening

January 29th, 2021. Saint Catherine's Monastery.

Hamir, the Baron of Frost, and Cassiel, the Daughter of Heaven, wasted little time with pleasantries. Once Hamir realized who he was dealing with, his desire to kill Heaven's Daughter immediately began an internal battle against his preference to stay alive. He shot ice out behind himself and rocketed horizontally to the right, barely dodging as Cassiel pounced at him and slashed where his neck was only an instant earlier. Her sword cut through the air and cleanly sliced through his ice trail, sending frost flying.

Hamir spun while flying away. He deliberately crashed his back against the cobblestone road in order to aim his palms at the Mightiest Lazarite. Fourteen icicles fired at Cassiel, and she quickly bent her body to avoid them. Her shield of light enlarged in an instant, with no need for complicated casting patterns or spoken words. It operated purely on the limits of her imagination, enlarging and hardening to protect her entire body at the speed of thought. The loud sounds of ice against magisteel rang out in the air, then Heaven's Daughter gave chase after her prey.

Just as Cassiel was about to make a killing lunge to behead her opponent who had fallen onto his ass, her eyes flicked up and to the right. She flapped her wings and reversed her momentum right as a pair of Demon Barons wielding a heavy greathammer and a pair of swords attacked her from above. These newcomers failed to kill her, and their weapons struck or cut the empty air, impacting the monastery's cobblestone road harmlessly.

"Zamiel! Duriel!" Hamir shouted, jumping to his feet. "Good timing! This bitch is Heaven's Daughter! Don't take her lightly!"

If Jason were here, he would surely recognize the two of them. They were the Battle Brothers, two bastards who had worked together in the future to kill Monster King Kar. Jason managed to revive him later, but Kar had lost all of his strength and became a cripple because of them.

In this era, they were only Barons... but they were still considered half-Dukes due to having reached the limits of the Baron level.

"Hehe, no need to get your panties in a bunch!" Zamiel chuckled. "She's just some ugly woman! What can a lone Lazarite do against three Barons?"

Cassiel put a little distance between herself and the three Barons. Despite their numerical advantage, her expression beneath her helmet was anything but frightened.

"Look at those eyes." Duriel said. "She actually still wants to fight. Dumb broad, hehe..."

Zamiel was the older brother, but he was smaller than his younger brother, Duriel. Duriel was definitely the more physically imposing of the two, with a body that dwarfed his older brother. But what Zamiel lacked in stature, he made up for in cunning and finesse.

"Duriel, you take point." Zamiel ordered. "Hamir! Help me flank her! Let's pressure 'Heaven's Daughter' from all sides and see how she handles the combined might of three demon elites!"

Cassiel took a step back. She watched as Zamiel jumped atop a nearby residential rooftop to her right, and Hamir pounced up into a tree to the left, hiding amidst its branches. Duriel moved directly toward her fearlessly. It was clear he intended to draw her aggression.

In an instant, she came to a decision. She put away her sword and shield, and instead summoned a bundle of chains. At the end of the chain's length, there was a small weight attached. She conjured this new weapon in an instant, drawing the three demon's gazes.

"Heehee. Gonna tie yourself up with those?" Duriel taunted. "Too bad I ain't into broads. Maybe if you beg him with a pretty expression, Hamir will turn you into his little whore and let ya go."

"Filthy hellspawn." Cassiel growled. "Your kind... must ALL be purged!"

She snapped the chain up toward Zamiel on the rooftop. The knife at the end of the chain flew toward his heart, but he cut at the holy weapon with his swords and deflected it.

What Zamiel did not expect, or perhaps realize, was that this was no ordinary length of chain. It was forged from Cassiel's imagination. It was an extension of her mind!

After batting the chain away, Zamiel jumped off the rooftop toward Cassiel's rear, but a surge of alarm shot through his mind. He looked back just in time to see that the chain

hadn't been knocked inert, but had instead coiled like a snake and pounced at him from behind!

"What? SHIT!" Zamiel cursed.

The knife made from holy energy at the tip of the chain plunged into a small gap in his armor and impaled his kidney. Zamiel lost his balance in midair and hit the ground with a heavy *thud*, gasping silently in pain as he grabbed the chain and tried to pull it out. However, the knife had morphed into a vicious barbed hook once it entered his body. It speared out in all directions and impaled even more of his vital organs. It finally morphed into a pair of razor-sharp swords that grew in size and bisected him at the waist.

Before Zamiel could utter a word, his body fell into two misshapen halves. He instantly died, unable to react to the Lazarite's secret technique!

Duriel looked at his leaping brother with a sneer. He didn't even have time to register Zamiel's sudden and unexpected death. He thought his brother was about to surprise the Lazarite by attacking her from behind, but at that moment, Zamiel's top and bottom halves fell to the ground, a dead look resting on his face.

"W-what?! Big brother? ZAMIEL?!" Duriel shrieked, horrified by the sight that met his eyes.

The chain turned into motes of light, then reformed in Cassiel's grasp. While Zamiel was momentarily struck dumb with fear and anger, Cassiel summoned a massive greatsword that was far lighter than it appeared. She flapped her wings and rushed at Duriel, intending to cut him down while he was momentarily shellshocked.

A burst of ice fired at her from Hamir's tree. He was already wary of Cassiel, having seen her instantly kill another Baron earlier, so Zamiel's death didn't root him in place with fear like it did with Duriel. Cassiel hurriedly stabbed the greatsword into the ground to stop her forward movement, barely avoiding a spear of ice that stabbed into the road where she would have stood only a moment earlier if she had kept going. She looked at Hamir with hateful eyes, then conjured fifteen golden knives that materialized behind her back and flew at him as if they were being controlled by telekinesis.

Hamir's heart turned cold. He quickly waved his arms to conjure a wall of ice, then flung it forward at the knives to break them. He partially succeeded. Some of the knives collided with the heavy ice and exploded into light, breaking on impact. But a few did not, and dodged to the side, flying in a circular arc as if they were birds of prey.

"Fuck, fuck, fuck!" Hamir cursed. "Lucifer's tits, this Lazarite is way stronger than the rumors said! DURIEL! SNAP OUT OF IT!"

Hamir panicked. He shot out two cones of icy wind to try and slow the knives before they could strike him, but he missed one. That knife pirouetted in midair, drawing his maddened, horrified gaze. It plunged into his heart and exploded like a grenade, sending fifteen pieces of shrapnel throughout his vital organs.

Like Zamiel, Hamir died instantly. The light dimmed in his eyes, and he plummeted from the tree to the soil below, landing with a wet and sloppy *thud*.

Only Duriel was left. He was so shaken with fear that he had no conception of what had even happened. As a battle-hardened warrior, he had fought many fearsome foes, but he simply wasn't ready to see his older brother perish within mere seconds. Zamiel's death rattled his simple mind and left him vulnerable to attack.

Cassiel finally closed the gap. She lifted her greatsword up, then mentally increased its sharpness to the limit, and raised its weight to more than three tons. She swung it down at Duriel from above, using gravity more than her own strength to empower her strike.

At the last moment, Duriel reflexively swung his greathammer upward in a panic, but her sword was sharp beyond comprehension. She sliced the hammer's handle in half with contemptuous ease, and her weapon cut through Duriel's body in a straight line, bisecting him with one motion.

Duriel looked up at the sky, his gaze frozen in death. His vision turned dark, and his bloody organs spilled out to splatter across the Monastery's grounds. He fell to the ground after a few moments, uncomprehending in regards to how he had fallen so easily.

In less than a minute, Heaven's Daughter had killed three lauded Barons. Powerful figures of Hell. Devils who had committed atrocities beyond compare.

Nobody was more shocked by this turn of events than Jason Hiro, who secretly watched the happenings on Earth inside the safety of Aevum. His heart beat wildly as the events of that single minute played out over the course of several hours, at a 365x time dilation, inside his realm.

This confirms it. Jason thought. *If there was any doubt before, I've definitely diverged from the events of my original timeline!*

Jason knew of Hamir. He was the Duke of Hailstorms in the future where Jason had come from. If he had died, there might still be some plausible deniability that perhaps the Hamir who Jason knew in the future was actually a resurrected undead demon under Mephisto's control or something. But now that Cassiel had killed Zamiel and Duriel, there was no doubt in Jason's mind. This timeline had greatly diverged from the future he knew.

The demons had launched an assault on Heaven far later in the timeline Jason was originally born. According to the spotty records he'd read, Jason estimated it should have taken them 25-50 years before they committed such a huge attack force to the battle. But his return to the past had changed things drastically.

The demon leaders were spooked. The arrival of two Trueborn Heroes (that they knew of) was a shocking revelation that forced them to accelerate their plans.

The Second War in Heaven was now happening much sooner than Jason predicted. His lack of a predictive MindCore had hurt him... even if only a little.

While he was certainly a little alarmed, his heart quickly calmed down. If it was inconvenient for him and his original plans, it also must be for Satan and the rest, too. They were not as prepared for this attack as they wanted to be.

And now? They had to face off against the Wordsmith... but they had *no* idea what his true abilities were.

Jason looked at the image of Cassiel, standing valiantly, covered in the viscera of Duriel, one of the demons Jason personally hated the most.

"Interesting." Jason commented to himself quietly. "I'll need to pay more attention to her. I didn't know Heaven's Daughter was so... *impressive*."

* * *

After slaughtering four demon elites, Cassiel barely took a moment to reflect on what she had done. She leaped into the skies and dissipated her light energy, returning to her standard sword and shield setup. Now that she had killed all the demons who witnessed one of her secret war strategies, it would be best to continue utilizing sneak attacks to slaughter the rest.

She looked down and two the left. Three Lazarites were deftly taking on a pair of Demon Lords. Two of the Lazarites wielded a sword and shield setup, like her, while the

third wielded a one-handed mace. They managed to kill one of the Demon Lords, while the second killed two of the Lazarites before the final Lazarite struck him dead. Of the five combatants, only one survived.

Upon a nearby sandy hill, five Lazarites nocked their bows and sniped demons from afar, taking special care to intervene and save any fellow Lazarites who had fallen into dire straits.

These were the most common Lazarite soldiers. Even the elites only wielded standard medieval weaponry and armor. Cassiel felt a twinge of anger, knowing they could do so much more. But at the same time, she remembered Raphael's plea.

Faith Energy is finite, my dear. It is well and good if thou doth wield thy powers to the fullest extent, but too many Lazarites unleashing such formidable powers would rapidly drain our reserves. All of angelkind would perish as a result. 'Tis best thou keepeth this matter to thyself, and we make it seem as if thou art a most unique individual among the Lazarites.

She understood Raphael's logic. All angels, including the Lazarites, required faith energy to survive. Without it, they would wither and die. There was only so much to go around, and while humanity might have more and more people capable of praying and giving their power to the Angels, there were also a vastly expanding number of Lazarites that needed that same energy to survive.

Furthermore, church attendance numbers were way down. Religion as a whole had been losing steam for decades, and now the energy traveling to Heaven was lessening by the day. It was one thing if Cassiel was a trump card for the angels, but if too many other Lazarites wielded their imaginations to the fullest extent, it would result in an inevitable loss for the angels someday.

At least, that was what Raphael had told her. Cassiel was no expert on worldwide religious politicking.

She pivoted to a new target. She spotted a pair of Demon Barons hiding out at the western edge of the battlefield, not directly engaging in the ritualistic killing of the remaining humans, and seemingly disinterested in joining their allies. But at the same time, they were demons. *All* demons had to die.

Cassiel flapped her wings. She dove from the sky and rushed at the male and female Baron. The female was the first to notice the incoming attack.

"Gressil! Watch out!!" She shrieked.

The male snapped his eyes up. He turned pale with fear, then he waved his hands and vanished.

Cassiel's eyes widened. *Invisibility?! No! It's an illusion, like Raphael!*

Unable to instantly locate the male, she pivoted to eliminating the female. Cassiel reared her arm back as she dove and took aim at the female Baron's neck.

Suddenly, the female vanished as well. A terrible sense of danger overtook Cassiel's mind. She flapped her left wing to push hard to the right, just as a beam of concentrated demonic energy fired into the sky, narrowly missing her.

If that attack had landed, Cassiel realized she would have been seriously injured, if not outright vaporized on the spot. The attack was ungodly powerful.

It came from a Demon Emperor!

"The only one allowed to bully my son is me, you stupid pigeon!" A female voice roared. At that moment, Lucifer, the Emperor of Providence, leaped into the air and swiped her razor-sharp nails at Cassiel's wing. She barely managed to land a glancing slash, but it threw Heaven's Daughter off enough that she ended up crashing into the ground and rolling her body to divert her momentum. Just as quickly as she crash-landed, she sprang back to her feet and held up her shield, enlarging it to a size big enough to protect her entire body.

And not a moment too soon. Lucifer's third eye shot a concussive beam at the Lazarite, striking her shield with enough force to send her flying backward!

"Aaah!" Cassiel cried, as her back slammed against a tree. Her expression turned grim when she realized she had inadvertently engaged in battle with not only a Demon Emperor, but one of the strongest and most frightening ones of all.

Her thoughts moved quickly. She realized the male and female Barons she saw from before must be related to Lucifer. One of them was named Gressil. Cassiel had no idea who he was, but the female looked a little familiar. She must have been Abby, the Baron of Happy Thoughts. A misnomer if there ever was any, because how could any demon produce a single happy thought in another entity? They were all villains who deserved death!

With her attention focused on Lucifer, Cassiel nearly jumped out of her skin when a massive Hellhound suddenly leaped at her right side from behind a house. She reflexively swung her sword at the massive beast, but the weapon passed through its body harmlessly, and it phased out of existence like a dream.

An illusion! Cassiel shouted in her mind. *It's that male demon! He-*

But it was too late. She'd already been distracted by the wolf and left herself open to attack. Lucifer took the opportunity to fire another compressed beam of kinetic power from her third eye, which slammed into Cassiel's arm and sent pain coursing through her body. Cassiel crashed against the wall, her armor only absorbing some of the impact. Her head was slammed against the heavy concrete structure hard enough to jar her senses. For an instant, she blacked out and lost consciousness.

Lucifer sensed that her prey had fallen. She grinned in excitement and leaped at Heaven's Daughter to finish her off, but a moment later...

Foop!

Cassiel vanished, and a familiar human wearing a nekomimi mask appeared, his rifle aimed at Lucifer's head. His body blurred for an instant.

"Shit!" Lucifer screamed, her pupils shrinking to pinpricks.

Blam!

A bullet fired from Cat Mask's sniper rifle. It struck the edge of Lucifer's third eye and snapped her head back with such violent force that her forward momentum reversed, and she screamed in pain as she slammed onto her spine.

Cat Mask lifted his hand. A glowing green stone shone with eerie light on one of his ring fingers, and a massive blast of wind fired outward, sending pieces of dirt, rock, and other fallen debris spraying outward in a cone. Gressil and Abby cried out in alarm when all this seemingly random debris struck their real bodies and broke the illusions keeping them hidden.

Cat Mask lifted his rifle. He took aim at Gressil, but then Hideki's body blurred and he quickly looked diagonally up and to the left. A pair of Demon Emperors, Belial and Diablo, were on the way, and would arrive momentarily.

"You got lucky again." Cat Mask growled at Gressil, before teleporting away.

Diablo leaped into the clearing not even a second after Cat Mask disappeared, his expression dim.

"Lucy! Are you okay?" Diablo asked, kneeling beside his ex-mate.

Lucifer held her third eye, waves of pain still radiating through her body and brain. Tears reflexively poured from her eyes. If Cat Mask's bullet had landed a centimeter to the left, he'd have likely put her eye out, and maybe even killed her on the spot. Unfortunately, even through multiple rewinds, he found it simply impossible to land such a perfect shot, considering her demonic reflexes, so he settled for this next-best option.

"Bastard! Spawn of a broodmother!" Lucifer roared with hatred and humiliation mixed together. "Twice! That Cat Mask has nearly killed me twice! His accuracy is uncanny!"

Despite not liking Lucifer in the slightest, Belial still walked over and healed her injury. For once, Lucifer didn't turn down her help. The pain was simply too unbearable. She desperately wanted it to go away.

"What's the status on the Monastery?" Diablo asked, turning his body from left to right to look for anyone who could give him an answer.

"Four Barons dead." Gressil said, lowering his eyes. "The Battle Brothers are gone."

"Duriel and Zamiel both?" Diablo asked with visible alarm. "Cat Mask killed them?"

"No!" Abby interjected. "It was that famous Lazarite. Heaven's Daughter. Emperor Lucifer nearly killed her, but Cat Mask intervened at the last moment."

"So that's what happened." Diablo grunted. "It seems we're close to securing the monastery. Hurry up and eradicate all the humans and Lazarites in the immediate vicinity. After we erect a barrier, we're moving on to Heaven itself. I want this place fortified within the hour, before Satan arrives. We need a forward base for Mephisto to erect his Death Gates."

Abby nodded, but she seemed visibly shaken by the multiple near-death experiences in a row. She was not much of a fighter, and preferred to avoid direct combat.

"Where is Ose?" Abby asked, looking around. "Isn't she supposed to be joining us?"

Lucifer massaged her eye. The pain was gone, but there was a phantom itchiness driving her batty now.

"No. My precious Ose told me she has a secret mission she's dealing with. We will not need to rely on her anyway... or do you think demonkind's leaders are so weak that her absence will spell our doom?"

"No, it's not that, I just..." Abby said hesitantly. "I was only hoping to see her! Oh well."

Gressil looked at Abby from behind. He said nothing. He looked away and rubbed his arm self-consciously.

"Don't you lot worry about Ose." Lucifer said with a mischievous smile. "I've noticed that since her ascension to Emperor, she's become frighteningly quick-witted. She'll go to any lengths to empower our future. Have faith. I expect big things from her in the coming days... or perhaps even *hours*."

Diablo smirked. "I would never dare to underestimate little Ose. She's one scary lady."

Part 668: Temporal Divergence

January 29th, 2021. Nevada, USA.

On the opposite side of the world from Saint Catherine's Monastery, in a place equally desertified where the sun scorched the sands and mountainous dunes until they were sometimes bleached white, there sat a secret Air Force base that had become a little too well-known for the liking of the military's higher-ups.

This base was known as Area 51.

It had become famous over the last several decades due to internet conspirators spinning all manner of strange, made-up tales. But it was, without a doubt, a highly remote and secure location ripe with secrets the United States would rather keep under lock and key.

It was night-time at the base. The sun would peek over the horizon within less than an hour, and already the faintest wisps of light were becoming visible over the hills. The stars twinkled above, and the lack of ambient background light made stargazing a fun activity for guards to momentarily relieve their boredom. The light pollution of the bigger cities was much more muted this far out in the desert, and the lights inside the base were not oppressive enough to drown out the stars.

Amy Sandoval was one of the many people watching the base's sizable outer perimeter. She was twenty years old, with blonde hair kept in a bob, and she wore a helmet with attached goggles that granted her enhanced night vision. As a night-guard, she wasn't anyone of particular note, but she was planning to apply for a special ops assignment later that year. She had heard rumors of a secret new military test being conducted by multiple branches, and she was interested in earning promotions quickly. It wouldn't do for her to waste these crucial early years. If she became known as a lazy bum or a floozy, her career would quickly stall out and eventually nosedive.

Amy had a nickname. *Ambitious Amy*. Some of the other soldiers mocked her for it, but most stayed out of her way. She was neat, orderly, and took care of herself and her weapons. She was a stickler for the rules as written; less so their spirit. If anyone on the base was going to get a promotion, she hoped it would be her.

She was only a Private now, but in the future... anything was possible.

Amy paced back and forth, alternating looking up at the sky, which had its stars become even more brilliant with the help of her night vision, and the horizon, where she would be able to see enemies coming from miles away, unless they were wearing camouflage capable of fooling her night vision. But that's why the other guards wore thermal and infrared goggles; to cover more possible avenues of attack.

"It's a cold one tonight..." Amy muttered to herself, as she exhaled warm air onto her gloved hands to try and heat them up. Deserts might be known for their scorching days, but they were equally fearsome when it came to their cold nights.

Suddenly, a light flashed in the sky above. Amy glanced up at it.

The light flickered for so short and brief a time that Amy momentarily thought she must have hallucinated it. Perhaps it was a shooting star, or one of the men on the base waved a flashlight up into the air, or-

BATOOOOM!!!

A horrifying explosion detonated half a kilometer behind Amy. Amy turned around to look at what had just happened, only for a brilliant light erupting from the explosion site to momentarily blind her, followed by a shockwave slamming into and throwing her body like a ragdoll.

"Aaugh!" Amy cried, as she was flung backward. She skidded across the sand, causing it to funnel into her clothing and boots, but she had no time to pay attention to her discomfort. She massaged her eyes and stumbled to her feet, visibly confused.

What the fuck? Was that a missile? Did somebody attack the base?

"HQ, this is Private Sandoval, something just exploded half a click from the base's entrance! It's inside the perimeter!" Amy shouted into her radio. "I'm going to investigate! HQ! HQ, can you hear me? HQ??"

She spoke into her walkie-talkie while jogging heavily across the thick and viscous sand, but all she received were crackling noises in response. In the distance, she could hear noises of confused yelling, followed by a few cries of pain. Whatever had detonated inside the base must have injured some people.

Suddenly, shouts of alarm rang out. Amy couldn't make out the exact words, but they were all angry and fearful.

Then, gunfire erupted. Bullets started flying in the air, and the sounds of whizzing shells in the distance made Amy dive to the ground.

What the hell are they shooting at? Have the others gone mad?! Amy screamed in her head.

Amy hunkered down on the ground, afraid of a stray bullet striking her from the people crazily shooting at... something. She was still too far away to make out what was happening, but she could swear she saw sparks of... *electricity*? Was that what it was? She zoomed her night vision goggles to try and get a better look, but what she saw only made her even more confused.

A few dozen troopers surrounded... something in the darkness. The muzzles of their guns flickered with light as they rapidly discharged bullet after bullet at the thing. Then, it moved, and its body began to glow.

Its body. That's right. It was a creature.

Lightning crackled violently around the monster. As the lightning became more energetic, Amy finally got her first look at the thing. It turned out to be... a person? A human? But with horns...

"HAHAHA! PITIFUL!" The creature suddenly shouted, its voice clearly female. "You ants think yourselves my match? You can all DIE!"

At that moment, something happened that was so horrifying, Amy's blood turned to ice.

The woman swept her palms in an outward motion. More than thirty lightning bolts fired outward in a cone before her, swept through the bodies of the brave men and women daring to try and take her down, and instantly killed them on the spot.

Some of the soldiers exploded into chunks of superheated meat and bone.

Many of them scattered to ash.

A few shuddered and spasmed in agony for a few seconds before their internal organs burst, causing blood to erupt from all their orifices.

None of them screamed. They couldn't. Her lightning was so powerful that it killed them all on the spot. Their bodily spasms were caused purely by involuntary neuro-receptor triggers.

Just as quickly as the woman attacked, the gunfire stopped. Every human in the immediate vicinity perished. All except for Amy.

Amy stopped breathing. She was so frightened that she started trembling from head to toe. She knew the people who had just been killed. She had served with a few of them since she joined the military two years ago. Being assigned to this base was supposed to be a fairly prestigious position, one that would accelerate her future career trajectory.

Now, she felt it was the most horrifying, stupid, unthinkably idiotic decision she had ever made in her life.

Amy knew that by the end of this day, she was almost certainly going to die.

Oh god, oh god, oh fuck, fuck fuck fucking fuck me... Amy chanted in her mind, unable to form a coherent thought.

Just as soon as Amy thought that the woman with the white hair was about to turn around and kill her, she didn't. The woman flickered away, seemingly out of existence, and a second massive explosion, right at the entrance to the underground base, detonated once more.

Amy's bones nearly leaped right out of her skin.

What is even HAPPENING right now?! She screamed in her heart.

Inside the White House, it was eight AM. President Johannesburg sipped his morning coffee and skimmed through a few reports on his desk detailing the movements of 'Red Sentients' southeast of Israel. These reports were sent over by the ISDF requesting recon drones to survey the area. Steven frowned.

Being the President is way more intense than I expected. He thought. *I expected it to be mostly about political dealings and pushing my agenda through, but instead I'm fighting a secret war against the fucking demons. What an absurd world we've all turned out to be living in.*

He quickly signed off on approving the reconnaissance drone support, but hardly had he started to move on to the next report before a frenzied series of knocks followed on the entrance to the Oval Office.

"Mister President! It's urgent!" Came the voice of a man Johannesburg begrudgingly recognized.

"Come in, Chris." Steven said, glancing at the door.

A moment later, the door flew open, and Steven's morbidly obese bastard of a Defense Secretary, Chris Brisker, charged into the room while waving papers.

"Sir! Sir!" Chris said, his jowls flapping with a mixture of fear and excitement. "It happened! The Red Sentients launched an attack forty-five minutes ago on one of Egypt's remote regions! We weren't able to predict their movements perfectly, but we know their target. They attacking the Holy Mountain next!"

Unfortunately, as the Secretary of Defense, Chris was one of a select few who had been debriefed on the existence of so-called Red Sentients. The thought that he knew such a precious national secret made him practically shake with excitement. He was a big fan of knowing things, and an even bigger fan of running his damn mouth. Steven secretly feared it was only a matter of time before he flapped his gums to the media and revealed the 'big secret'.

The more Steven thought about the modern world, the more he thought keeping a secret as big as the existence of the metaphysical world under wraps was an impossible task. With smartphones in every citizen's hands, and the media practically drooling for a crazy scoop to splash across their front pages, it was a miracle the secret hadn't been let out. Or maybe it had, and the Men in Black were better at their jobs than he knew.

"An attack?" Steven asked, directing his full attention to Chris. "Tell me more."

And so he did. Chris quickly sat down across from Steven, blabbering incessantly about every minute detail he knew, even as Steven read the reports Chris had handed him.

"They're setting up a forward position. Something defensible they can use to flood the entrance to Heaven with hellspawn. It seems they're either going to construct or already have constructed a barrier meant to keep missiles from hitting their ops-base."

Steven fell silent for roughly five seconds. He tapped his chin thoughtfully.

"So? How will we respond?" Chris prompted impatiently. "I say we go in guns blazing! Send in the boys!"

"Mother of god, Chris. Calm down." Steven said, glowering at his cabinet-member. What was he thinking, putting this moron in charge of defense? First chance he got, he'd send in the MiB to wipe Chris's memory and put someone less idiotic in charge. "A military response is appropriate, given the angels are our nominal allies. But this is happening on Egyptian soil. We need to inform them first and see if they can prepare a response first. Appraise President Abdul of the broad situation and see what his response is. We'll need six hours to coordinate a proper response before we can even think of moving in troops."

Chris's voice lowered. "But... what if the demons aren't interested in taking their time? They seem to be moving quickly. Blitzkrieg, shock and awe, that sort of thing. We might show up only for the battle to already be over."

"I don't care how powerful the demons are." Steven stated. "War is a logistical nightmare. The demons are trying to gain entry into a hidden realm with only one major entrance. Once they're inside, they might be able to open portals of their own to flood inside, but even gaining entry will not be easy. Heaven has already been invaded once, and the angels took great care to fortify the entrance far beyond its ancient strength. Coupled with billions of Lazarites at their beck and call, they have a lot of meat they can throw into the demon grinder if they must. They will be able to stall until we arrive."

Steven tapped the report with one finger. "I noticed it said here that the Hero known as 'Cat Mask' appeared on-site and nearly killed Demon Emperor Lucifer all by himself. That means he and his son, as well as the Illuminati, have likely been informed of the matter and are monitoring the situation. It's imperative the United States takes action, but we must not be hasty. It would send the wrong message. We must project strength and confidence. Rushing in blindly will indicate a state of panic and fear on our end, which will increase the demons' morale. We don't want them thinking we're *afraid* of them, do we, Chris?"

Chris looked at Steven blankly. "Uhh, right! You said it yourself, Mister President. Look strong, not weak."

Steven quietly sighed. He really needed to replace Chris, and soon. The guy practically had a black hole of intelligence in his head. If his father hadn't been a sitting senator for two decades, he'd probably never have risen in the political theater.

"Alright, you're dismissed, Chris." Steven said, waving his hand. "Tell the war room to prepare a recon report on the composition of the demon army. I'll join them in thirty minutes."

"Sure thing, Mister President!" Chris blubbered, standing up quickly and nearly knocking over his seat. He quickly exited the war room, making Steven sigh for perhaps the hundredth time.

"I *need* to get rid of him." Steven muttered to himself.

He glanced at another set of papers on his desk, with the words *TOP SECRET: Project Iron Bone* written on the front.

"Not yet." Steven whispered. "Hopefully it'll be ready within a few years. Perhaps even before the end of my first term..."

Jason Hiro sat inside a secret room somewhere deep within the heart of Aevum. This room was sealed behind multiple layers of security, including spells that hid his location, his aura, and prevented trace-backs of his soul link.

That last part was especially important. Four phantasmal versions of Jason sat in lotus positions around him, their ghostly bodies unmoving. Their bodies glowed with an eerie blue light, and their eyes shone even brighter still. They looked at Jason emptily, not a single thought stirring within their souls.

These were Jason's newest creations: Spiritual Incarnations.

Not like when he fought Ose and stupidly brought his soul out of his body, and not like her Astral Body either; these Incarnations were intimately linked to his soul. In fact, they were severed pieces of it, which were directly controlled by Jason, but indirectly separated from his True Body. Any higher level Psion that knew of these incarnations would be shocked, if not horrified out of their mind! It was a similar principle behind how their True Souls remotely piloted false bodies across the cosmos!

Jason's four Incarnations each remotely piloted a Dronesmith v2. One of those Dronesmiths hung out with Daisy and her friends, while the other three executed other missions. By now, Daisy had grown suspicious of the fact that her 'father' was acting a little weird, and because she couldn't sense his soul or his thoughts. Naturally, Jason had already fortified his Mind Realm to prevent random telepaths from reading his thoughts,

but the security measure was even more potent when he controlled a Dronesmith. They didn't have any thoughts to read in the first place!

His Mind Realm was directly shielded, his body was hidden within a secret room which itself was hidden within the secret realm of Aevum, and his incarnations were only indirectly linked to his body via spirit links. This meant that the situation he had encountered in the past where Hope was able to trace a link from the Dronesmiths back to Jason and then yank him back into Realspace would never happen again!

Jason had learned from his past mistakes. He still had a long way to go, but perfectionism was the enemy of progress.

Around Jason, a new version of the Spynet had been created. It no longer used computer or digital television screens, but instead highly optimized spiritual displays that could output everything from sights and sounds to smells and emotions.

Jason had been hard at work developing the new and improved Spynet v2. This one came complete with Psion detection algorithms, including activity trackers for high level Psions, as well as Demonic Energy detectors.

Jason pursed his lips. He turned to look at the slow-moving image of his father battling Demon Emperor Lucifer at Catherine's Monastery.

"Hmm. It might be time for Project Great Deceiver to move to Phase Two." Jason said to nobody in particular. "The demons know about the legendary Cat Mask, and his fame is starting to grow. If I send the 'Archseer' into battle, I can probably stir up some trouble. But Ose is starting to worry me a little. She and Satan had a private discussion about something I wasn't able to intercept. What did she tell him...?"

Jason glanced at one of his Incarnations. "Any thoughts?"

The blank-eyed spiritual construct said nothing. It simply continued to creepily stare directly at him, an invisible leyline of energy transmitting between its 'brain' and his.

"Well, whatever." Jason muttered. "Even if Ose figures out everything, including the fact I'm a time traveler, and she uncovers how my powers *really* work, it won't matter. Aevum is hidden halfway across the galaxy in a location too remote for her to reach. I have the absolute advantage in terms of abilities and resources."

Jason chewed his lip.

"What's the worst thing that could possibly happen if she figures out too many Truths I'm trying to keep hidden? Well, my father's information on the future could decay quickly. The demons could start making moves he never expected. In fact, this attack on Heaven is happening far sooner than he ever expected. I'd be tempted to download his memories if what I saw wouldn't scare the shit out of me. God knows what horrors he's seen across tens of billions of years..."

Jason blinked. He looked at the Incarnation to his right. He looked through its eyes and sighed in relief.

"Oh, good. So. Raphael's 'Cosmic Realm' exists and so far I haven't found any Kolvaxians inside of it. That means they weren't around by this point in the timeline. I probably have a while before they arrive or are created."

Jason tapped his knee thoughtfully. "Kolvaxians. Are they invaders from another galaxy? A biological experiment gone wrong? Gone *right*? Did the Volgrim create them, then play stupid about their origins? Can I trust anything Unarin told me? And how did they breach the Cosmic Realm anyway? Could they be related to Andromeda..."

Jason's eyes flashed. He suddenly smiled as he looked to his left.

"Yes! You found it! Right at the edge of the Hell Harbor system... as expected."

Elsewhere in the galaxy, one of Jason's Dronesmiths materialized inside a different realm, one where the stars had completely disappeared. It flew toward a massive Cube seemingly lightyears in the distance, and when the Cube expanded in the drone's field of view, it drew closer and closer until it was able to circle around and locate the entrance.

Jason took direct control of this particular Dronesmith. He levitated into the Cube and immediately came into contact with the ten Sentry Stars that activated when they sensed the intruder's presence.

[**HRRM BRRRM BRMM!**]

Their loud, vibration-like language struck the Dronesmith, only to bounce right off. Inside Aevum, Jason uttered a Word of Power.

"**Deactivate.**"

All ten Sentry Stars turned off at the same time. They floated inertly in place, posing no harm to Jason.

For the first time, Jason took a serious look at them. He inspected their internals with his Wordsmithing and his hyper-advanced MindCore. He was shocked out of his mind at what he saw.

"My god! What high level artifacts! These Sentry Stars don't use human technological principles, but instead alien ones that fuse with angelic mana to create a masterful fusion of technology and magic! The energy pathways alone!! If I could reverse engineer these concepts to the fullest extent, I could increase my efficiency of absorbing interstellar energy into Aevum by a factor of ten!!"

He was shocked out of his mind! Whatever Camael had done to create these Sentry Stars, her artisanal abilities were far beyond his. For the first time ever, he began to feel a sort of engineering 'hunger' toward Camael. He desperately wished to pick her brain and see what he could learn.

Consensually, of course. He wasn't about to strap her down to a mad scientist's torture table and suck out her brain juices or anything psychotic like that. Unless she deserved it. Who knew what atrocities she may have committed in the past before Raphael's mind-wipes?

Jason's excitement increased even more the longer he looked at their schematics. "These are no ordinary constructs. Each one must have required a massive number of exotic materials in order to make them so large, which means Camael spared no expense. It seems they're even better at battling Cosmic entities than they are mortal ones, provided they have enough power fueling them. That makes sense, too! Camael designed them to protect the Cube in an era where Apex Cosmics roamed the Milky Way freely. She must have feared the dragons would come to free their captive brother..."

Jason turned his gaze toward the center of the Cube. His expression turned solemn as he uttered a Word of Power and became disappointed by what he found.

His body flickered. The Dronesmith teleported to the Cube's center, and he found the control matrix in the same condition as when he stumbled across it in the future. There were images of ancient monsters emblazoned on the control cube's six sides, and a massive hole had been torn out of one of those images, ruining it beyond recognition.

"The dark dragon isn't here." Jason muttered to himself quietly. "That means it escaped well before the Energy Wars. As expected. Leviathan must have escaped and traveled to Earth to hide long, long ago."

Jason's mind stirred. He thought about what he'd just said, then slowly shook his head.

"Was it Leviathan? I don't know... this seems a little out of his *modus operandi*. From what I've gleaned, he's not a particularly malicious bastard, full of anger and rage. He seemed quite content to sleep in a cave and leave everyone else alone. And it seems dragons were not the actual 'bad guys' of the Primordial Era. They were simply prey for the angels. Prey that fought back and ultimately lost the war. In a way the dragons were... tragic figures."

Jason's eyes flashed.

"Then who was the dark dragon contained within this prison? If it wasn't Leviathan, could it have been a different one? But Dragons shared their power. If Leviathan was as strong as he was while there was still another dragon alive, then killing one of them would double the strength of the other!"

A chill went down Jason's spine. "That would mean if there really was another dragon, then it would have become twice as strong as it was after it escaped the Cube, given Leviathan died at some point. When did he die though? I don't think I ever learned that specific information. Amelia never told me..."

The Dronesmith levitated around the small inner cube. It was only 'small' relative to the primary cube enveloping it, because in actuality it was two kilometers wide from edge to edge. Its interior had to be vast in order to accommodate its ancient long-escaped prisoner.

Jason finally reached the side that held the engraved image of the Phoenix. When he arrived, he spotted the 100-foot in diameter red orb that housed the Phoenix. With Jason having prematurely shut off the Sentry Stars, his previous interaction of the Phoenix exiting their central cerebral units to meet him never happened. Instead, the orb flickered to life and glowed a dim red color.

[Hello, friend!] The Phoenix said, as she suddenly exited her control unit. She flew around Jason excitedly, a tiny orb of glowing red energy that examined him from head to toe. [How odd! You look a lot like the Big Mean Dummies! Your body is really strange. But it seems nice!]

Jason smiled. [Hello, Phoenix. I'm here to save you from your boredom. Do you know who I am?]

[No idea!] The Phoenix chirped. [But you seem like a friend, so I'll call you Friend!]

[I am your friend, and you can just continue calling me that if you want, or you can call me Jason. Anyway, let me examine your control matrix.]

He mostly ignored the Phoenix. He felt a little bad, but she had already endured eons of boredom and loneliness. A few minutes of not having her questions immediately answered wouldn't hurt.

"**Examine. Diagram. Inspect.** Hmm, so it's like that. Marvelous. In the past, I was too ignorant to comprehend the greater profundities of technology, but now I am truly awed by Camael's work. She is far, far above my level when it comes to her artifacts' refinement of stellar and celestial energy."

Jason looked up at the Phoenix's glowing orb. [Phoenix, do you know who Camael is?]

[Nope!] The Phoenix replied. [Her name sounds nice. Is she a friend, too?]

[She is.] Jason answered. [But she can't talk to you right now. She lost her memories, just like you did. Well, I'll have to solve one problem first before solving another. Let's see if I can juice you up a bit...]

Jason frowned. When he died in the future and reawakened inside the Cube, Beelzebub was there, and he had apparently used some technique to revive the Phoenix back to its original form. How did he do it?

Jason traced his memories. He recalled that Beelzebub had mentioned being linked to the Phoenix somehow. That made sense. Jason knew Beelzebub was linked to it because the damned artifact had revived Beelzebub and recognized him as her 'friend'. Luckily, it all worked out in the end, and Beelzebub ended up saving Jason's life.

In his heart, Jason had finally forgiven Beelzebub. Not fully, but most of the way. Beelzebub hadn't killed Daisy, but he did kill countless other humans. Beelzebub had converted to humanity's side in the end. He wasn't irredeemable, but a victim of the system he was raised in.

If Beelzebub could become an ally to humanity, then didn't that mean other demons could, as well? Jason wasn't sure. He didn't want to end up sacrificing millions of humans to find out either. In the future, he would give demons chances to amend their ways, but he would never be as foolish as he was in his youth and give that trust freely and without restrictions.

Jason shook his head. He focused on the Phoenix again and started to think.

Beelzebub used his 'link' to transfer his Middle Cosmic energy to the Phoenix. I'm not a Middle Cosmic, so I can't do that. But maybe I can use a different method?

Jason examined the Phoenix's Control Unit more carefully now that he had a goal in mind. He quickly found that it was actually a machine capable of absorbing and controlling vast amounts of energy in order to empower itself and its internal systems.

Jason marveled at his new understanding of *Angelitech*. Camael's comprehension of its principles were far above his own, and as a novice, he was only beginning to tap into the greater possibilities such technology held.

From what he could tell, the Cube was actually incomplete! It had never been finished. Camael clearly intended not to make a prison for a dragon with it, but... something else.

Jason spent several Aevum hours grokking this information. He closed his eyes and started rapidly disassembling and reassembling the Cube and its control unit, along with the Sentry Stars, bit by bit. Such a vast construct was not simple to dissect. It took serious effort on his part to do so.

After hours of engrossing research, Jason came to a conclusion.

"This was originally just a casual experiment. Camael repurposed it into a prison for the Dark Dragon, but that wasn't the Cube's original purpose. That may even be why it was able to escape. The dragon grew in power after Leviathan died... no, was it when Leviathan died? Is Leviathan even dead?"

Jason wasn't sure. He hadn't been able to locate the dragon, but he knew due to Gressil's existence that it was possible to hide from his Wordsmithing. He had considered the possibility that Leviathan's death gave the 'dark dragon' the power to escape the Cube, but perhaps it escaped even earlier than that. Jason simply wasn't certain.

"Anyway, the Cube wasn't originally made to be a prison. Based on what I've gleaned, Camael was wavering between making a new realm of some sort, similar to Heaven, where the angels could reside without leaking their cosmic power, but she was also thinking of constructing an intergalactic warship. Something she and the other Angels could enter and use to travel across the cosmos, attacking their enemies among the other Rulers and Sentients across the universe. That's why the Cube is able to move around in the higher dimensions. But ultimately, she failed to realize either of her visions..."

Jason pondered for a while. In realspace, this happened over the course of only a few seconds. But in Aevum time, he spent several minutes.

"It would be a waste to simply turn the Cube into a second Aevum. I need to give it a unique purpose that makes the best use of its capabilities. Well, for now at least, I'll just worry about re-energizing its power matrix and bringing it to Aevum's sector near the galactic core. That should only require a few real-weeks of travel time. Plenty of Aevum-years for me to think about what to do with it by the time it arrives."

Jason spent another hour or two reconstructing the Phoenix's control matrix. As he did, he chatted the little bird up and had a good time getting to know her again. This time though, he was not in the dark about her capabilities, and could awe her with his knowledge.

[That's right. Ice cream is very cold and delicious.] Jason said. [Once I build you a new body, you can have a taste of it. You'll probably melt it once it gets too close to you, but you can still savor its sugary goodness.]

[Wow! Wowee, friend! I can't wait to taste the creamed ice!] The Phoenix chirped. [Is my matrix thingy finished yet? Is it fixed? Is it? Is it?]

She pestered him multiple times, but Jason never lost his patience. If it wasn't for the Phoenix, he would never have revived, traveled back in time, and found out that his daughter was still alive.

Jason's vision momentarily dimmed. Even if Daisy was alive, and even if he'd met his father, Phoebe was still gone.

His wife was dead.

Thinking about Phoebe... always caused a cloud of despair to swallow his mind. It was impossible to feel good about life when she had been a key driving force that always kept him going.

Right now, he stayed alive and fought for both Daisy and Hideki's sakes. But if they passed, Jason believed he wouldn't have the motivation to go on any longer.

They were his weak points. If the demons ever killed these last two people who kept him clinging to the mortal coil, Jason really didn't think he had it in him to keep living.

* * *

Eventually, Jason finished his work. He reignited the Cube's power source, summoned the Sentry Stars, and initialized its jump drive. The Cube leaped into P-space and began traveling out of the Hell Harbor system toward the southern edge of the Milky Way's core.

Jason left his Dronesmith inside the Cube to monitor its situation and control its progress. He activated its autonomous control mode, allowing the drone to pilot the cube without Jason's direct intervention.

Jason had long decided he would never again create clones of himself. Hope was an unfortunate accident that led to the worst disaster of Jason's entire life. Therefore, Incarnations were Jason's next best option. They were linked to his mind, and he could control them directly, but they could also be set to act autonomously, making the same general choices he would make if he controlled them, but at a fraction of the brainpower.

This allowed him to switch them to autonomous mode where they would transmit information to him, and even fight or explore on their own, but they were not clones with unique minds of their own. They were merely low-bandwidth copies of Jason's exact personality that he could retake control of at any time.

"They'd be even more effective if I instead had a MindCore installed that was focused on swarm-like manipulation of drones. I could autonomously pilot tens, hundreds, even thousands of Dronesmiths. But I wouldn't give up my GenesisFrame for anything. The ability to invent and summon objects at rapid speeds is way more valuable to me. I'll just have to deal with 'only' projecting myself into a few specific places at a time."

One of Jason's four drones was talking to his daughter and her friends. Another was exploring the Cosmic Realm. A third was navigating the Cube to Aevum's star system.

As for the fourth one...

Jason glanced behind himself at the fourth Incarnation, which also stared at him with blank, glowing eyes.

"The demons are about to attack Heaven. Ose is attacking Area 51 for some reason. Should I intervene in one of those two situations?"

Naturally, his Incarnation did not offer a reply. Jason simply liked to talk out loud because hearing himself speak often helped sort his thoughts.

"No. My dad can handle those situations. I'll let him do what he thinks is most appropriate. Even if the demons end up utterly slaughtering all of angelkind, I won't

intervene. Compared to the threat of the Psions, the demons are nothing at all. They don't even know about Demon Deities in this era. No, I need to keep my eyes on the bigger picture..."

Jason summoned his to-do list, which by now had become a lot longer and better organized.

REACQUIRE ORIGINAL POWERS AND ABILITIES AT OR EXCEEDING PREVIOUS LEVELS (Progress: 85%)

REBUILD INTERNAL MIND REALM; ESTABLISH NEW 'SMITHY' PROTOCOLS; RETURN BRAIN FUNCTION TO SUPERHUMAN LEVELS (Plan exchanged for new one)

CREATE NEW MINDCORE, USE IT TO SPEED UP COMPLETION OF OTHER PLANS (Done)

CONSTRUCT TIME ACCELERATED REALM (Progress: 47%)

LOCATE CAMAEL'S CUBE, MOVE TO AEVUM'S STAR SECTOR (In-progress)

CONSIDER MOVING ENTIRETY OF MARIE'S FUTURE REMNANT OASIS FACILITY TO SECRET DIMENSIONAL SPACE (Undecided)

PROJECT 'GREAT DECEIVER' (Phase 1 Complete, Phase 2 Pending)

INVESTIGATE VOLGRIM, DETERMINE THREAT LEVELS (Progress: 5%)

EMPOWER HUMANS, REMOVE FLAW (Progress: 3%)

PACIFY DEMONS, PREFERABLY FORM ALLIANCES, BUT EXTERMINATE IF NECESSARY (Not started)

DETERMINE RELATIONSHIP WITH ANGELS - DECIDE BETWEEN STATUS QUO, ALLIANCE, OR EXTERMINATION (Not started)

LOCATE BAHAMUT, SAVE PHOEBE (Not started)

LOCATE BLACK WITCH, DETERMINE CURRENT STATUS (Not started)

* * *

As Jason looked at these options, his thoughts turned chaotic. There was still one entry on the list he desperately wanted to act on, but it would be selfish to jump the gun. He wanted to save Phoebe and prevent Bahamut from torturing her and all the other humans, but he had yet to look for them.

Finding out Amelia's location would be important, too. She knew the status of Leviathan and could give Jason answers about the dark dragon.

Was it Leviathan that escaped the Cube? Or was it a different 'dark dragon'? Jason wasn't sure. His intuition leaned toward the latter, but it was always possible he might have misread the situation...

Suddenly, Jason's attention shifted. He sensed an unknown entity had been teleported into the containment area of Aevum, a place Jason had told his father he could always send someone if he wanted to safeguard their life but wasn't sure if he could trust them. It wouldn't leak the existence of Aevum, and whoever was teleported there wouldn't be able to cause any serious problems. After all, the holding zone was constructed of high level reinforced Wordsmithium...

When Jason investigated the newcomer, he was slightly startled.

"Her? How could it be her?"

Jason opted to send his final Dronesmith into the containment area. There, he found a woman with white hair spilling out of her helmet, her angelic wings unmoving as she lay on the ground, dazed and injured.

"Cassiel...?" Jason asked, as he approached her.

The woman stirred. Despite wearing a helmet that covered her face, Jason knew what she looked like. He had seen her in the future, after all.

"Ugh... you... who are you?" Cassiel asked. "Where is this place?"

She found herself inside a metal warehouse-like area. Not too large, big enough to fit a few trucks inside, with medical devices, containers filed with various food types, and other assorted items strewn around in a fairly efficient hospital-like layout.

"My name is Jason Hiro." Jason replied. "I am the Archseer."

Cassiel raised her head. She looked at him through the slits in her helmet and frowned.

"You? You're that second Trueborn? Raphael has spoken of you."

Jason knelt beside her. "Are you injured? This facility can heal you."

Cassiel clutched her ribs and winced. "Emperor Lucifer... ugh... she struck me a most grievous blow. I'm lucky I didn't perish on the spot. How did I even arrive here?"

"My father brought you." Jason said, taking care not to reveal too many details. "Here, let me help you up. Rest in this chair. The time flow here is quite fast. If you spend a day here, only a few minutes will pass in the real world."

She nodded at him, but her movements were guarded. "In that case, I offer my thanks, Archseer."

"Just call me Jason, Cassiel." Jason said, as he took her hand and pulled her to her feet.

When she stood up, she looked at him and frowned. "So I didn't mishear. You called me that name again. You must have me confused with someone else. My name is *not* Cassiel. She was one of the ancient Archangels. She is long dead."

"Oh! That's right." Jason said, suddenly remembering she never actually told him her name. "Then how should I address you?"

Cassiel looked at him for a moment, then shook her head.

"Heaven's Daughter is just fine. My name is... not important anymore. I am not worthy of it."

Jason raised an eyebrow. *What did she mean by that, exactly?*

"Alright. That name's a bit clunky, but it'll do." Jason replied.

As 'Heaven's Daughter' sat in the lounging chair and relaxed a bit, she merely nodded.

"Yes. It will."

Part 669: Double Drone Decision

January 29th, 2021. Aevum's Containment Area.

Heaven's Daughter eyed the man standing before her. She sensed that something was a little 'off' about him, and it had to do with the Heroic Energy she sensed. Or rather, the energy she didn't sense.

"You are not the first Trueborn I've met." She said, leaning back in her chair. "But your 'divinity' is... the thinnest. It's as if you barely possess any mana at all."

"That's because this isn't my real body." Jason said. Even though he knew anything he told her would likely make its way back to Raphael and the angels, he also knew being more forthcoming would benefit the forces of 'good' in the long run. 'Good' of course meaning anyone aligned with his interests. "This is a robotic drone that I am controlling with my mind."

To prove his point, Jason casually popped his left arm off to reveal his Dronesmith's mechanical parts inside its shoulder joint. Then he popped the arm back into place with practiced ease.

"A robot?" Heaven's Daughter asked. "...I was under the impression that humanity had a long way to go before robotics became so... advanced."

Jason smirked. "My Heroic Title is 'Archseer'. That should tell you everything you need to know. I can see into the future, and thus I was able to procure highly advanced technology decades, even centuries ahead of time. Pretty impressive, right?"

The Strongest Lazarite did not appear moved.

"Perhaps you are unaware of this fact," she said slowly, "but Archangel Camael is a Seer, and I converse with her frequently. I have learned many Truths about how foretelling the future works. What you have described is fundamentally *impossible*. One cannot glean such precise information from a hazy series of possible events... especially now that the timelines have been... *Shattered*."

Jason's heart skipped a beat. He looked at her with a faint flicker of surprise, but this flicker was enough to confirm her suspicions.

"If you're just going to lie to me, this conversation is over, 'Archseer.'" Heaven's Daughter said mildly. She looked off to the side, deliberately breaking eye contact. "I have nothing to say to those who would lie to my face."

Jason fell silent for a few moments. He looked at the side profile of her helmet, which hid her face. He could barely make out her eyes between the visor's slits.

"You're right. I lied. My true title is not 'Archseer.' And I am not a prophet. I am an architect. I wield the power of Imagination to defeat my foes."

Heaven's Daughter flicked her eyes back to meet his once more. This time, she didn't look away.

"You said... Imagination?"

"That's right. I cannot give you the full details, because every person who knows adds another link that could undo my strategic advantage over demonkind. But, to reassure you that I am no Dracula, nor that I hold no ignoble intentions, I can offer you three guarantees."

Jason continued.

"First, multiple other Trueborn have taken to following my orders. My father, Cat Mask, is one. Jepthath and Madam Mildred are two more. Others will join them soon enough."

"Jepthath." Heaven's Daughter repeated blandly. "I know his name. Raphael does not trust him."

"Second," Jason continued, "It was I who created this time-accelerated realm you are currently residing within. One day in the outside world equals one year in here. I have already spent several years rapidly formulating my plans and building up my contingencies. Once a year has passed from your perspective in Realspace, this realm will be unrecognizable. I will have hopefully amassed a lead the demons cannot hope to contend with."

Heaven's Daughter stood up. She activated her magic and sent out a pulse, but when it struck the walls, it bounced off and was unable to pass any further.

"How do I know you're not lying?" She asked. "I can't sense any 'time acceleration' happening. And I can't sense outside of this extravagant 'box' you've stuffed me inside."

"I have to maintain security protocols." Jason said softly. "I'd love to give you a tour, but what happens in Aevum is top secret beyond anything you can fathom."

He continued. "Thirdly, I am not a Seer, but I *am* a time-traveler from the future."

This caused Heaven's Daughter to have a visible reaction. She took a step back and looked at Jason in shock. "You're lying!"

"I'm not." Jason said calmly. "It's a long story, and I can't give you all the details, but I can tell you that I was frozen in cryosleep for 100,000 years, and when I woke up, the angels were nearly all dead, the Earth was destroyed, and humanity had been wholly enslaved by the demons."

He paused.

"You were there, too. In fact, you were the last living angel among all the Lazarites and Purebloods. The Archangels had all been killed and ended up in their rings. Your situation was..."

Jason fell silent.

"...It's better you don't know. No matter what, I aim to ensure such a horrid future does not come to pass."

Heaven's Daughter looked at him for a long time without replying.

"You knew me in the future?" She asked.

"I did. This is your face, as I remember it." Jason said, before secretly using Wordsmithing to instantly create a photo of her and send it to his Dronesmith.

When his drone waved its hand and produced a photo of Heaven's Daughter out of thin air, her shoulders slumped slightly. She carefully took the picture from the Dronesmith and looked at it in disbelief.

"That... that's me? But... I seem so... lean. Frail. Malnourished, even."

"The future I came from was a future you should pray you never experience." Jason said solemnly. "I really cannot afford to give you any further details- huh?"

Jason became momentarily tongue-tied when Heaven's Daughter heaved a small sigh, reached up, and pulled off her helmet, revealing her face.

She was extraordinarily beautiful, with soft eyes and long white hair. Unlike the 'Cassiel' Jason remembered, this younger version seemed more heroic and valiant. There

was plenty of fight in her eyes, contrasting sharply with her beauty. She embodied the ideal of a 'Valkyrie' from top to bottom. He had no doubt she was born for combat.

"There is no point in hiding my appearance if you already know it." She said.

Jason's Dronesmith, luckily, did not reveal any weird expressions. As beautiful as she was, his thoughts toward her were the same as if he were admiring a wonderful painting. She could not create any ripples upon a heart which had already been hardened by loss.

"Am I still to refer to you as 'Heaven's Daughter'?" Jason eventually asked.

"My name is unimportant. I live according to my title." Heaven's Daughter said quietly.

"Very well." Jason said.

* * *

Some time passed. Jason healed the Strongest Lazarite's injuries, and she regained her full fighting power.

"Please return me to Earth." Heaven's Daughter requested. "Heaven is under attack."

"Not for another hour or two, in realspace-time." Jason said. "That's hundreds of hours for us. I still have a matter I need to speak to you about."

"Me?" She asked. "Surely, Archangel Raphael would be more appropriate."

Jason felt a bit of pride that his drone didn't even twitch an eyelash at the mere mention of speaking to Raphael directly. As if he would ever want to do such a stupid thing like converse with that silver-tongued, lying sack of...

"Well, the thing is, I want to talk to you about Lazarites." Jason said, changing the course of the conversation to something more appropriate. "Specifically, I need to know how Lazarites function, how they fight, and how I can help them become better at combating the demons."

Heaven's Daughter hesitated. She looked at Jason with that same obvious distrust she did earlier in the conversation.

"Have I said something wrong?" Jason asked, noticing her hesitation.

"Not... not exactly." She replied, still keeping her guard up. "Look, I... I don't see why you need to know this information. This isn't any of your business, is it?"

Jason fell silent. He looked at Heaven's Daughter, noticing now that she had become visibly discomforted by the direction the conversation was taking.

"It seems I'm treading upon a secret of some sort." Jason said, as he looked away and thoughtfully tapped his lips with a finger. "Let me guess. Raphael told you never to speak of the power the Lazarites commanded. Is that why you're hesitant to answer?"

"I... no! Of course not!" Heaven's Daughter stammered. "It's- it isn't like that at all..."

"Well, let me see if I can paint a picture without you saying a word." Jason said slowly.

He waved his hand, and through some mechanism Heaven's Daughter couldn't divine, two dimensional video screens materialized in midair all around the room and began playing various recordings of recent events.

Her pupils shrunk to pinpricks. Many of the videos were of her, when she was practicing her magic in Heaven. She would conjure whips and chains, summon large rifles, and even materialize land, sea, and air vehicles around herself. But other videos were of normal Lazarites who could only conjure simple weapons, armor, and other basic implements.

"You-you-you've been SPYING on me? On Heaven?!" Heaven's Daughter roared angrily, looking at the 'Archseer' with a mixture of disgust and horror.

"I am currently observing 713,698 individuals across the galaxy." Jason replied. "I understand if you feel disgusted, thinking I'm some 'peeping Tom', but I assure you, my intentions are purely practical. I need to collect information on how humanity, the angels, the demons, and all the other species operate. Based on what I've observed, it seems the Lazarites are able to conjure images of 'items' based on their imagination, yet you are the *only* Lazarite able to create complex machines and weapons."

Heaven's Daughter looked at Jason with rapt attention. She swallowed heavily, uncertain how she should respond.

"This leads me to two distinct possibilities." Jason continued. "The first is that you are a very special Lazarite gifted with a unique ability to control your power at a higher level than any of the others. The second is that all the Lazarites can do what you do, yet they do not, either because they believe they cannot, or because *someone* has convinced them they cannot."

Jason paused.

"Someone, such as, say... Raphael?"

"Lies and slander!" Heaven's Daughter snapped. "Do not speak ill of the Archangel of Wisdom! He has the best of intentions for angelkind!"

"The road to Hell is paved with good intentions." Jason replied, his tone bland. "There are other possibilities too, granted. Maybe all the Lazarites and angels share power from the same well of Faith, so if too many Lazarites use their powers all at once, it will rapidly drain Heaven's reserves. Thus, training just one elite champion, such as yourself, will prevent such a catastrophe from happening."

"You... you HAVE been spying on my conversations with Raphael!" Heaven's Daughter exclaimed. "Stop pretending to have deduced all of this! You won't con me so easily!"

"So I was right?" Jason asked, looking at her with a face full of innocence. "I can't believe I got it on the first try! I had a few other guesses too, but now it seems I won't even need to say them!"

"Stop toying with me." Heaven's Daughter said, her eyes turning cold. "I do not appreciate being manipulated."

With her sudden change in attitude, Jason finally sobered up.

"Fine, you got me again. I spied on a lot of 'secret' conversations in Heaven. I've roughly deduced the situation of the Lazarites and just needed your confirmation to be absolutely certain. How about we move on to the real meat of the discussion?"

Suddenly, a second Jason appeared beside the Dronesmith. Only, this Jason was not a drone. It was his real body.

Heaven's Daughter immediately noticed the difference. She sensed a well of mana within his real body, and while it was nowhere near the level of ancient powerhouses like Samson or Arthur, it was a little above average compared to most Trueborn.

"So... this is the real you?" She asked doubtfully.

"Hi. It's me. I'm Jason." Jason said, smiling and waving at her. "The real reason I brought you here is because I have determined the Lazarites are a powerful piece I can put into play against our shared enemies. I don't know exactly why Raphael wants only you to be the Strongest Lazarite, or why he doesn't elevate a second or a third Lazarite, but if there are any practical reasons, I might be able to solve them."

"For example," Jason continued, "if the problem comes from a lack of Faith energy, and the fears that too many Lazarites wielding too much Imagination could ultimately drain Heaven's reserves, then I might be able to provide a massive wellspring of mana for your kind to draw from. If the real reason is *ideological*, however... that will be more problematic to solve."

"What do you mean by that?" Heaven's Daughter asked. She narrowed her eyes.

"You know what I mean." Jason said solemnly. "The truth is... Raphael fears the Lazarites. Right now, they may outnumber the Purebloods a thousand or even a million-to-one, but they're quite weak and the Archangels could dispatch them en-masse. But if all the Lazarites became as powerful as *you*? It would prove extremely difficult to quash an insurrection."

Jason tapped the side of his head. "Think about it. Does Raphael truly value the Lazarites and their lives? Or does he place them on a tier below that of the Purebloods? Don't you think that, aside from you, he treats your fellow former-humans as expendable pawns he can throw away at his whims?"

Heaven's Daughter frowned. She wasn't talented in the art of conversation, and was not a particularly deep thinker. She preferred to close off her thoughts and focus on tasks and missions given to her by Raphael, so she had long grown used to simply doing as he commanded.

"I... I don't know. I don't like how this conversation is making me feel. You're calling my mentor into question."

Jason decided to ease off. "Well, I'm sorry. How about I try a different approach? If you think Raphael has good reasons for limiting the power of the other Lazarites, do you also think he would object if you, specifically, were made a lot more powerful?"

That seemed to pique her interest. "Raphael is always eager for me to grow stronger. What do you have in mind? I won't necessarily refuse... or accept. You'll need to convince me."

Jason smiled. Finally, the **true** reason he'd brought her to Aevum could be spoken.

"Heaven's Daughter, I have an idea to outfit you with an advanced piece of technology known as a MindCore. My father has one, and so do I. They augment our mental

capabilities in specific ways, and I think that for you in particular, it could become a game changer."

"A MindCore." Heaven's Daughter repeated. "I assume it's some sort of brain enhancement. A computer chip slotted into my head?"

"Not exactly." Jason said. "Are you familiar with the Mind Realm? I imagine you must be, given your natural talents."

She nodded. "The Mind Realm is a place inside every person's brain that can contain a small world. However, 99.99% of Sentients will never notice its existence. Only high level mental masters will innately tap into it, though some like me can observe it when guided by said masters. Raphael awakened mine a long time ago."

"As I suspected. You probably already have a rudimentary form of a MindCore in your Mind Realm." Jason muttered. "Can you walk me through how it works? Or would you rather I take guesses until I get it right?"

The Lazarite shuddered slightly. She found it a little creepy how easily he could 'guess' Truths about herself. Maybe they really did know each other in that distant future.

"It's... ahh... basically, I can construct objects using my Imagination." She began to explain. "But in the heat of battle, doing so would be extremely slow and cumbersome. So, instead, I create blueprints during my free time, and I save those blueprints as ready-made objects I can summon at a moment's notice. However, if they are destroyed in reality, the blueprint is also destroyed and I'll have to rebuild it later."

"How many blueprints have you made so far?" Jason asked.

"One thousand, seven hundred and twenty." She answered with a hint of pride.

"Not bad. You're thousands of years old, right? You've had a lot of time to build up your collection."

Her face flushed beet red. "Thousands of years old?! I'm not even *six hundred*! You make me sound like an old hag! Do you hear me, you foul-mouthed cretin? Don't just run your mouth about a woman's age so glibly!"

Jason blinked. "Oh. Sorry. I didn't mean any offense. Actually, I'm a few hundred years old, too. We're pretty similar in age."

She calmed down a little. "Yes, well, in any case. I've had maybe five hundred years to build up my 'stockpile' but all the best designs have come in the last hundred. After all,

humanity's technological development speed dramatically accelerated around the early 1900s, and I attended several colleges during the last century to keep up to date with their warfare systems. I'm still quite far behind the modern military paradigms though. I've been thinking it might be time for Raphael to arrange a mission for me with the modern United States military so I can get a feel for how their weapon systems function."

Jason listened to her words and nodded. "I can tell you don't really trust me, which is fine, but how about I show you what you could accomplish if I were to create a customized MindCore for you?"

Without waiting for her approval, Jason waved his hand in the air.

"I **look** up at the **stars** and dream of **pyromania**, illu at **ell** velu!"

Heaven's Daughter looked at him in surprise. She understood his English words, but the sentence itself was utterly nonsensical. The seemingly made-up words that came after only added to the mystique of whatever spell Jason was 'casting'.

An instant later, a wireframe orb materialized above Jason's upraised palm. Spiritual images of many miniature Jasons began hammering and reshaping it at the speed of light, leaving afterimages as they raced around. He put his full mental focus on creating a rolling omni-ball with turrets mounted on the side. It was a war machine meant to roll across urban environments and unload bullets into the enemies of its driver.

While simplistic, the machine rapidly took on a defined form, and even gained a coat of paint when Jason chose to draw the orb itself with splotches of light and dark maroon colors, while also etching hexagonal black lines all across its surface. These were not merely colored lines, but actual texture to give the ball some 'grip' on smoother surfaces. The weapons gyroscopically mounted onto the 'death ball' were painted pure black, and gave it a formidable black and red color palette. A classic choice as far as color design went.

Two minutes later, Jason held the finished blueprint in his palm and looked at Heaven's Daughter.

"Well? Want to give it a try?"

Confused, she reached out her hand to touch the blueprint, and it instantly appeared inside her Mind Realm. This startled Heaven's Daughter, making her jump slightly. After a moment of introspection, she realized that Jason had not only created the blueprint, but

he had also somehow perfectly matched it to her Mind Realm's mental wavelength. She was thus able to perfectly assimilate its knowledge.

She took a few steps backward, then waved her arms. In an instant, she conjured the combat omni-ball around herself, enveloping herself in a rolling weapon that could shoot twin machine-guns capable of locking onto targets within 300 meters.

She rolled around it for only a few moments before de-summoning the weapon and marveling at its complexity.

"This... this machine is far more advanced than anything I've made to date! It's at least at the level of modern US vehicle combat. It may even be more advanced than that..."

"Honestly, omni-balls are not great as far as weapon platforms go." Jason said casually. "If I spent a bit more time thinking about it, I could have designed a much more effective and deadly tank or fighter jet. I just chose the ball because it was simpler and more time efficient."

Jason remained silent for a while. He allowed Heaven's Daughter to think about the implications of what she'd just seen. She summoned and examined the omni-ball construct, sighing several times as she admired its complex internal components.

"This is... two orders of magnitude more complex than anything I can design." She finally admitted. "And it would take me six months, maybe even a year. You did it in two minutes."

"That's because of my MindCore." Jason said, tapping the side of his head. "Mine is quite appropriate for someone like you, but I am actually thinking of letting you pick from an assortment of MindCores. I have a few variants available that you might consider worth trying."

"Oh? And you will give me this gift for free?" She asked, narrowing her eyes in suspicion. "I'm not signing any contract, lest you turn out to be the Devil himself. I also expect to talk the deal over with Raphael first."

"All matters can be discussed." Jason said neutrally. "But it's not exactly 'free'. You'll be my guinea pig. I've only ever installed a MindCore on myself. I need more capable test subjects before I can consider mass-creating these for others. Humanity needs all the fierce warriors it can get. The coming war is going to change the face of the Earth... and

possibly even destroy it. I'm simply doing everything in my power to prepare for that future calamity."

Heaven's Daughter nodded slowly.

"Alright. My curiosity is piqued. Tell me more."

Part 670: Mindcores v2

January 29th, 2021. Aevum's Containment Area.

Jason summoned a spiritual viewscreen for Heaven's Daughter. He stood beside her and proceeded to show her a series of possible MindCores he had devised; each one far more detailed and advanced than the ones Mildred had merely described for Jason in the past.

"This is the MindCore I'm using. It's a more advanced version than mine, so its performance will be superior. It's called the GenesisFrame v2, and it's based on human design principles. It functions by accelerating your creative capabilities, allowing you to rapidly design and invent things at a vastly higher level than before. If you care a lot about creativity, like writing, painting, music, and other such pursuits, it's also great at those."

The Lazarite's eyes lit up with excitement. "This MindCore is incredible! It explains the speed of how you were able to develop that blueprint for me. And you say this iteration will be even better than yours?"

"Yes. Mine is an amazing creation, but flawed in many ways because Madam Mildred designed and built it with my help over an unfortunately short period of time. This version will be a lot easier and less painful to install in your head, because it will be a little more compact and a lot more energy efficient. If you and I tried to design the same weapon using my v1 and your v2 GenesisFrame- well, we couldn't do that because everyone's creativity is different... but if we *theoretically* could, you'd probably be ten to fifty percent faster in finishing it up and ironing out lots of small details than me."

Jason paused, then shook his head. "Even though this MindCore seems extremely appealing to you, I actually don't think it's the correct choice."

"And why not?" Heaven's Daughter asked, turning her head to look at his side profile while frowning slightly.

"The reason is simple." Jason answered, meeting her gaze. "I'm an inventor. You're a warrior. This MindCore has nearly zero benefit in a combat situation. Sure, it will improve your general thinking capabilities a bit, but when you end up fighting a Demon Emperor, you'll only benefit based on the blueprints you've made ahead of time. It won't improve your mid-combat skills, your deductive reasoning, your speed of thinking outside

of creating new Imaginary Objects, and so on. Unlike me, you also have a hard limit on what you can Manifest. I can create objects which exist permanently. You can only summon temporary objects, *and* you're limited by your mana. I'm guessing it also costs mana to maintain, which comes from a source outside yourself?"

The white-haired woman nodded slowly. "Yes... all of that is true. Hmm. You were able to make a blueprint for me, then pass it to me. Couldn't you keep doing that?"

"Yes, but I have countless other projects to maintain. Frankly speaking, empowering you is only a small side project. If you refuse, or this fails for some reason, I have many other options to explore. Instead, it would be a better idea if there were a second or third Lazarite at your level who could obtain this MindCore. They could create weapons, vehicles, and machines for you, and you could hone your skill with them."

"Lazarites can pass blueprints to one another?" Cassiel muttered with realization. "Of course. I knew that was possible, but it never was any use to me because we only use the technique to have older Lazarites teach newer ones the basics of summoning weapons and armor. For me, I'm not allowed to pass my knowledge onto others..."

She suddenly paused, and a look of guilt washed over her face. Jason noticed.

"Raphael's orders?" He asked.

She didn't reply. It was confirmation enough, not that he didn't already know the answer.

"Well, anyway, if you decide to go that route, I'm happy to grant a different Lazarite the GenesisFrame." Jason continued smoothly. "They can be your Blueprinter. Let's move on to the other MindCores I think would be more valuable."

Jason changed the image on the screen. Heaven's Daughter was immediately drawn in to the imagery of a Mind Realm populated with angelic architecture, pure white marble buildings towering into the sky, datacores infused with holy light, and other design paradigms that spoke to her on an emotional level.

"I'm not showing you the OmniRecord because I think it's better than the other options. I just wanted you to know of its existence before we move on." Jason said.

"This OmniRecord is truly beautiful. It feels like I would own a miniaturized Heaven within my Mind Realm if I picked it." Cassiel said quietly.

Jason glanced at her. "Has Camael told you about Solomon's Crown? Do you know how it functions?"

The Lazarite nodded slowly. "Yes. I know of its functionality."

"That's what the OmniRecord is. Nothing less, and nothing more. It has infinite data storage, and it would accelerate your thinking speed in all general tasks. However, Solomon was fearsome not only because of these two abilities, but because of his innate ability to swallow information with merely a touch and then rapidly comb through and assimilate that information rapidly. The OmniRecord would not have those functions, nor would it contain the tiniest fraction of information his Crown does. It would be like walking into an empty library you need to fill yourself, step by step."

Jason paused before adding, "Also, it's basically the MindCore my father has. I didn't make it for him. Mildred did. Please don't tell anyone."

A white lie. Heaven's Daughter wouldn't know the difference, and Jason would casually tip off Mildred not to leak any information on the matter. Trying to explain that his father had a melted down Solomon's Crown inside the center of his head would be hard to explain, and Jason was unwilling to tip anyone off about his father's Rewinding power.

"I see..." Heaven's Daughter said, slightly dejected. "It truly is not very suited to my situation. I would much rather you install the GenesisFrame over the OmniRecord... at least if these were the only two options."

"The best is still yet to come, but don't look down on the OmniRecord. If the only thing it did was accelerate your thinking speed and give you infinite, perfect eidetic memory, it would still improve the basic 'you' on a fundamental level. Faster thinking speeds would mean you could forcibly develop new Blueprints and perceive the movements of high-speed entities like Ose more easily."

"Ose?" Heaven's Daughter asked.

Jason was mildly surprised. It seemed that either Heaven didn't know about the newest Emperor's sudden Ascension, or Raphael hadn't had time to inform Heaven's Daughter.

"A new Demon Emperor. She is a technologist; utterly unique among her kind. She is extremely speed-focused, brilliant beyond compare, and lethal in combat. If you face her

without speedy reflexes... you will likely die instantly. Knowing she's been empowered is part of the reason I brought you here. I'm already working on a plan to kill Ose, but if it failed and you ended up assassinated, we'd lose a powerful player in our upcoming war. Best to solve that problem now."

Heaven's Daughter took his warning seriously. "Alright. Show me the other MindCores."

And so he did. Jason first showed her the demon-based HellProphet. "This MindCore would probably work better for Camael, since it's all about prediction. But I know she wouldn't go for it. The fact it's based on demonic biology and architecture makes it a no-go."

The Lazarite looked slightly repulsed, but her reaction was much milder than Jason expected.

"Archangel Camael would not easily dismiss anything that could empower her." Heaven's Daughter said.

Jason scoffed. "It's demonic in design. I'm not saying it wouldn't be useful, but she's an Archangel. They're all set in their ways."

A moment of silence followed. Jason met the Lazarite's even gaze. He was surprised by the turmoil in her eyes.

"The Archangels are... not a monolith." She said quietly, lowering her eyes to the floor. She shuffled her feet. "Camael, especially, has seen many things. Many horrifying things. She does not tell others directly, especially Raphael, but I have gleaned bits and pieces during our private discussions. I think if you were to mention this 'HellProphet' MindCore to her, she would not reject you outright."

It took ten seconds before Jason recovered. He was truly surprised by Cassiel's words. As far as he knew, all the Archangels, barring Samael, were holier-than-thou righteous fiends with sticks up their bums. But based on the words of Heaven's Daughter, such an assumption might not necessarily be true...

"If I get to talk to her, I'll bring it up." Jason said, before moving on. "This next one is based on monster biology. If you want to become the most powerful warrior with the keenest instincts, you can't go wrong with choosing the QuantumReflex. It's even better than the one Mildred originally described to me. You'll gain the ability to sense auras

much more keenly, track enemies, react to things before they happen, and all sorts of other stuff. Your reaction speeds will be even greater than with the OmniRecord. Even your senses of smell and hearing will improve!"

"It won't improve my creation powers though?" Heaven's Daughter asked.

"No." Jason said. "This is the rawest, purest combat-core. Your control over your muscles will improve. If you exercise your body, you'll gain strength faster than ever by enhancing the muscles specific to your needs. When fighting enemies, you'll be able to deduce how they fight nearly instantly. You won't be distracted by tricks. You won't falter in the face of deceit. If you choose this one, we'll definitely need a second Lazarite to assimilate the GenesisFrame so they can pass blueprints on to you."

The Lazarite's posture remained unmoved, but a hint of excitement boiled under her surface.

Over the years, she had become a little... bored. Raphael rarely deployed Heaven's Daughter to the frontlines. He always had her training in Heaven, polishing her skills, maintaining morale among her comrades...

But she was, in truth, a goddamned battle-maniac. She loved to fight. The Mightiest Lazarite ached to draw blood. She hungered for battle, and most importantly, for validation. She wanted to become famous, feared, and a fighter beyond compare. All to live up to the ideal of that precious memory in her heart...

"You really seem moved by this one." Jason observed.

"I... cannot lie. It is extremely appealing. But I will withhold judgment."

"Alright. Here's the last one, for now anyway." Jason said. "This is RealitySim; the MindCore I think will be most suitable for you."

He proceeded to explain how it worked.

"This core is focused on granting you the power of Simulation. I've specially designed it so that it can function based on your Lazarite powers. You will be able to collect data on entities, items, tangible and intangible concepts, and other such things. Then you will be able to model their behavior and create simulations which operate at extreme speeds inside your Mind Realm. For example, you lost against Lucifer, but with the RealitySim, you could simulate the battle in preparation of a future fight. Next time, you will be much more likely to win."

Heaven's Daughter appeared unconvinced. "This... seems fine, but I feel that the GenesisFrame is better for my creation abilities, and the QuantumReflex for pure combat."

"The RealitySim is indeed probably not as holistically good for you as the GenesisFrame I use, but I really would prefer if you chose it." Jason said earnestly. "I need data on how the RealitySim functions. You aren't only going to simulate one type of thing, you know? You can simulate multiple different realities at the same time. The most incredible thing about the RealitySim is that it will vastly improve your control over multiple thoughts."

That sparked her interest. "Explain more. I'm not fully understanding."

"Look, just imagine this for a second. You have fought lots of demons, right? So you use that information to create a RealitySim instance in each of them. Then you place a copy of yourself inside those sims. You let your *copy* fight them for a hundred time-accelerated years. Then you integrate the copy's knowledge back into your brain!"

This finally broke through the mental barrier of Heaven's Daughter. "Wait, so couldn't I use this ability mid-battle, so long as I found a minute or two of breathing room? Couldn't I simulate myself creating artifacts of many different types? Couldn't I simulate entire realities where the laws of physics differ from our own?!"

"Right! Exactly right!" Jason praised. "Don't get me wrong, my GenesisFrame is ideal for me because it improves my actual creativity, but you're already plenty creative. You're probably smarter than I was before I obtained a MindCore, because you're much older than I was and you've learned how to create entire false constructs using only your Imagination. That means your baseline would be higher than mine, and even more importantly, you would need not only a MindCore that is useful before combat, but one that is useful during and after it. You'll make the best use of preparation time, and improve your battle instincts."

At last, Heaven's Daughter felt the full temptation of what Jason was offering.

She was hundreds of years old, yes. But her enemies were thousands of years old. Satan alone had absorbed the souls of so many humans, demons, angels and Titans that he had become qualitatively stronger than she could ever hope to defeat.

But what about Lucifer? She was beatable. If Heaven's Daughter could simulate combat against her a handful of times, let alone a thousand or a million times, she was

sure she could come up with a counter for her abilities.

"I won't lie. Of all the MindCores, the most tempting to me on an emotional and personal level is the QuantumReflex." She said, surprising Jason. "I like that I would be able to react and improve myself dynamically on the spot. But I really, *really* do need improvements to my creation speed, and I'm not sure I should rely on other Lazarites to create the weapons I'll ultimately be using. Ever since you made that omni-ball in less than two minutes, it left a deep impression on me."

She licked her lips and looked at the selection of DataCores with hungry eyes. Each one, including the HellProphet, which she definitely wasn't going to pick, had something to offer. All of them would still improve her beyond her current circumstances. Three of them were especially desirable; she just had to decide which one best suited her needs.

Unbeknownst to the Lazarite, Jason's thoughts momentarily darkened.

If Gressil regains his power from the future, the QuantumReflex would probably give her the edge she needs to fight him off, maybe even kill him. I'd hate for anything to happen to her... but then again, maybe the RealitySim would suffice if I...

The last possibility that popped into his head sparked Jason's interest. He carefully looked at her.

"You're a mature woman, perfectly capable of making your own decisions. I want you to pick the RealitySim, but I'll respect any choice you make. If you think one of the others best suits yourself, don't feel obligated. I'm sure I can find someone else it would work for."

In fact, Jason was already thinking of one other such person. Daisy's friend, *Nadia*. She seemed to have the perfect skillset to master the RealitySim's core and tertiary functions. Even if Heaven's Daughter picked it, it wasn't as if he couldn't reuse a particular MindCore on multiple people. He just wanted to be as diverse as possible with which ones he handed out during these early years.

Heaven's Daughter slowly lifted her eyes. She stared at Jason with an inscrutable expression, her face giving no hints as to her thoughts.

"In the future... you said we were friends?" She asked.

"No, not friends. Honestly, we barely spoke." Jason admitted. "I found you in a... terrible situation. I organized a team and we rescued you from a monster most

despicable. I can't say I'm doing this because of any particular friendship we shared or anything like that. It's mostly just self-interest on my part."

"You're an honest person." She said quietly. "You remind me a lot of the one I admire most. I always looked up to her, even after she passed. Sometimes, I feel I can never quite achieve what she did, in those few short years. I never feel as if I'm enough. But... I don't feel that way when I'm around you. You make me feel... safe."

She lowered her head and closed her eyes. Heaven's Daughter quietly prayed, a sight Jason might have found amusing, given the seeming pointlessness of it. But she was so earnest, he didn't want to interrupt her.

After a few minutes of silence, she raised her eyes again.

"If you want me to pick the RealitySim, then I will. I'll do so... for her sake. That's what she would have wanted."

"She?" Jason asked.

"The person I admired most in the world." Heaven's Daughter said. "My sister. She was a Hero like you. A Trueborn. She's the reason Raphael picked me to be the so-called Mightiest Lazarite. Her glory was so bright... it left a halo around me."

"But I wasn't as good as her. I've never been as good as her." She said quietly, looking off in the distance. "You probably know her name. She was Jeanne d'Arc. The Maid of Orleans. One of humanity's five mightiest Heroes."

"You're Joan's sister?" Jason asked, shocked beyond his imagination. "What... but how... why didn't you tell me...?"

He wanted to add 'in the future', but obviously she wouldn't know the answer. Instead, the Lazarite took that as a question about the current era.

"It's not that I distrust you. But I just... I'm not good enough. I feel little self-worth. No matter what others say about me, no matter how they praise me, I always doubt myself. I'm afraid that if they knew who I was, they would expect too much of me... only to be disappointed. Raphael tries to be considerate, but I see the truth in his eyes. He wishes he could have resurrected my sister as a Lazarite. Instead, he's had to make do with me."

Tears welled up in the Lazarite's eyes. She squeezed them shut and wiped the few drops away.

"My real name is Catherine. Catherine D'Arc. I died when I was only six years old. I was raised by Raphael in Heaven. He took care of me, taught me to wield my magic, and turned me into the 'Mightiest Lazarite.' But I'm really nothing special. I'm nothing compared to Jeanne. You shouldn't expect much from me."

Jason's lower lip trembled. He hesitantly reached out and touched her shoulder, which caused the woman to heave a soft sob.

"Catherine. That's a beautiful name. You shouldn't judge yourself based on such strict criteria. You're an amazing person. Even without a MindCore, do you have any idea the feats you achieved during the upcoming war? In the era I came from-"

"It doesn't matter!" Catherine shouted, pulling away from Jason's grip. Her grief left him stunned. "You already told me! Humanity fell! The angels perished! Only I was left alive, likely because of my cowardice! Captured by the demons, no doubt tortured and raped for a hundred thousand years! Who cares what accomplishments I made? I let everyone down! I ran away to save my own skin, and I was 'rewarded' with being the sole survivor of the angels. What a great victory I earned! What a *feat*!!"

Catherine practically spit the words out. She clawed at her eyes and turned away, unwilling to let Jason see her tears.

"I don't even know if this MindCore will even do anything for me!" Catherine shouted. "I'm just hoping it'll make me less of a failure! Because that's all I am! *That's all... I am.*"

She slumped to the ground and wrapped her arms around her knees. The previously formidable Lazarite... seemed almost like a child who had been violently beaten. She withdrew into herself. She visibly lost all pretenses of being a fine, valiant warrior.

"Nothing you've said is true." Jason said, after a minute of silence. "You're not a coward. You're terrifying. During the Energy Wars, you were such a menace to the demons that they dispatched multiple Emperors to try and kill you. I don't know how everything went down, but you managed to kill Emperor Red Raven all by yourself. It was a feat that Raphael told me about, so I know he wasn't lying. You only ended up captured because the demons used despicable tactics after you had heroically rushed into one of their enclaves to save some captured angels."

Jason mixed in truths and lies. He really didn't know the exact circumstances that had left Catherine in Gressil's claws, but now wasn't the time to stick purely to the facts.

"The truth is, without this MindCore, you're already on the path to becoming an Emperor-slayer, like your sister." Jason said. "I can only imagine how scary you'll become after I install it. I'm really looking forward to seeing you forge an even greater legend than you did in my former timeline."

Jason knelt down beside Catherine. He gently squeezed her shoulder again and smiled. She sniffled, then looked up at him through teary eyes.

"You're... not lying?" She asked quietly. "I killed Red Raven? But... he's one of the strongest Emperors... it doesn't seem possible..."

"I don't know how you did it. I don't know anything about Red Raven." Jason said honestly. "But I do know that if you did it once, you'll do it again. You're way too hard on yourself. Raphael picked you to be the Strongest Lazarite for a reason. He and I may have our differences, but he was right to make that choice. Will you trust both our judgments and let me elevate you to the next level?"

Catherine's eyes met Jason's. They glittered with remnant tears, as well as determination.

"I... alright. Okay. If you really think so... I'll... try to believe in myself."

"Atta girl." Jason said, his smile a little wider than before.

His hand lingered on her shoulder for a moment. Then, he pulled away and stood up.

"I need a few hours to prepare. Stay here and rest. If I sent you back to Realspace, I'd just bring you back to Aevum in less than a minute anyway. I'll give you some materials to read regarding the operation. They'll help ease any worries you might have."

Catherine wiped her eyes. She remained seated, but the depression she felt before had greatly eased up.

"I understand. Thank you... Jason."

"No thanks needed. It's my pleasure." He concluded.

Without another word, Jason turned and walked away. His body vanished as he returned himself to Aevum's Control Matrix, along with his final Dronesmith.

He had work to do.

Part 671: Area 51 Assault

Recommended Listening

January 29th, 2021. Area 51, Nevada.

A violent explosion rocked the upper area of the underground Air Force facility. Alarms blared inside the facility as emergency notices began playing.

"ATTENTION ALL PERSONNEL: THIS IS NOT A DRILL. A HOSTILE LIFE FORM IS ATTACKING THE BASE. ALL HIGH LEVEL OFFICERS WILL RECEIVE EMERGENCY INFORMATION REGARDING THE LIFE FORM. DO NOT APPROACH WITHOUT AUTHORIZATION. DO NOT ENGAGE WITHOUT PROPER EQUIPMENT. IF THE LIFEFORM APPROACHES: FLEE. IF YOU CANNOT FLEE, ATTACK. CONTACT WILL ALMOST ASSUREDLY MEAN DEATH. REINFORCEMENTS ARE ON THE WAY."

Demon Emperor Ose sneered. "Damn right it'll mean death! But lucky for you, killing a bunch of vermin isn't why I'm here! Hahaha!!"

A massive blast door made of 12-inch thick reinforced Titanium, 36-inch thick concrete, and several extra layers of durable materials stood in Ose's path. It had been shut the moment she arrived at the base, but it didn't deter her at all.

Ose flexed her arms. Her pupils ignited with blue light as energy crackled around her body. A mad grin seized her face before she launched forward and sent a punch imbued with the nuclear force at the wall.

KATHOOOM!!

The underground facility lurched as if a terrible earthquake had just struck. Countless men and women multiple levels beneath Ose lost their footing and fell on their asses or sprawled to the ground. The sound of *the lifeform* attacking the base above made their hearts pound in their chests.

Quickly and efficiently, information rapidly began disseminating among those in the need to know.

"Are you fucking kidding me?" One man shouted in disbelief. "A demon? A literal demon? This has to be a joke!"

"Corporal Winters! This is not a joke, and you'd damn well better not treat it as one." An old man with a commanding mustache named Robert barked back. "This information comes straight from the Pentagon. These creatures have been spotted before and are considered Top Secret. Their existence represents an existential Threat to humanity. We must kill the entity at all costs! If we cannot kill it, then we must apprehend or trap it."

"What about the projects on the bottom level? If this monster starts wreaking havoc, the research materials won't be salvageable!"

"All we have to do is hold out for an hour or two." The commanding officer stated. "Spec Ops are on the way."

The entire base violently shook again. An alert popped up on the commander's datapad.

"The Demonic Entity has broken through the first Reinforced Barrier. Son of a bitch! It's like a walking thermonuclear bomb! We're getting casualty reports from the exterior… seems more than 45 soldiers are already dead, with scientists and civilians soon to join them."

"We just received word that there's one survivor from the surface. It's Private Sandoval. She says she witnessed the Entity's initial attack. We'll have to get her statement as soon as possible."

* * *

Men and women in the Command Center at the heart of Area 51 quickly gathered whatever information they could on their attacker. It didn't take long before they were able to identify the Entity as a female demon possessing some sort of lightning or electrical based energy powers. Beyond that, the reports were sporadic and uncertain.

"Contact! Alpha Team is taking point. Bravo will arrive in T-minus thirty seconds."

"We've lost contact with Alpha team! We're uncertain if this is due to electrical interference or because the hostile has neutralized them."

"Bravo Team initiating contact with the Entity…"

"Bravo Team's connection has also been lost! God dammit, what is going on up there? Are they dead? If so, how could they die so quickly?! Is the Entity unstoppable?"

"Teams Delta and Gamma are moving to intercept, but they have two minutes before reaching the contact point. They're wearing special equipment to disperse electrical

energy."

"Status?"

"Unclear. We're getting scattered reports the Entity has broken through Level 3's Blast Doors. Waiting for next contact."

"Contact! We have contact! Gunfire exchanged... shit! Delta and Gamma are down!"

Commander Robert, the highest ranked officer at Area 51, maintained a fearless expression. However, his heart secretly quaked. He was supposed to retire in a few years. Now it seemed he wouldn't be seeing his family again.

"Good news!" One man exclaimed. "The Pentagon says a 'special asset' will be arriving on scene and that we just need to hang tight!"

"Let's hope they arrive quickly." Commander Robert said solemnly.

* * *

Ose's palms swept left and right. She sent millions of volts of electricity surging into the metal walls, control panels, and other components of the underground base. Those bolts arced toward any living entities, namely humans, and electrocuted them until they stopped moving. With ruthless speed and efficiency, she charged into Area 51 with bold intent, killing tens of humans at a time while cackling evilly to herself.

"What fun this is! I just love slaughtering you all like flies to a bug zapper! What pitiful worms you are! I never could have done this when I was a Baron, but now that I'm an Emperor, I'm unstoppable!"

Her body was insanely strong. Even the weakest Demon Emperor was tens of times hardier than the strongest human bodybuilder. Ose was especially strong and could casually pick up and throw modern tanks into the sky with ease. Her bones were hard enough that when she punched a titanium blast door, it was the door that suffered; not her.

She broke through multiple doors, the sealed facility posing no barrier to her. Eventually, she reached the third level, which was seven floors above her ultimate destination. Area 51 was 17 floors deep, but the place she cared about, her ultimate goal, was only on the 10th floor. She would reach it in no time.

A group of armed soldiers bravely stood between her and her destination. They took cover behind the edges of doors and other nearby natural barriers while firing their rifles

at her. Ose sneered. She held a metal pipe she had casually ripped out of a wall and swung her right arm at inhuman speeds.

With her multiple Mind Realms working together, Ose was able to accomplish something she'd never even tried in the timeline Jason first saw. Her right arm was controlled by the Mind Realm designated 'Secondary', which perceived time 100x faster than ordinary mortals. When the soldiers fired bullets at Ose, she watched those pitifully slow pieces of shaped metal fly at her head and body...

Then her right arm began to move.

It spun around at a speed so shocking that some of the soldiers nearly dropped their guns in fright. Like a hurricane, Ose's arm revolved around her body at lightning speeds and instantly swatted aside tens of bullets every second, her metal pipe serving as a makeshift baseball bat. She swept the iron pipe from left to right, up and down, diagonally, all while deliberately batting the bullets back at the humans.

Not even five seconds after the humans started firing, countless bullets ricocheted back at them and tore through their armor, as well as the small parts of their bodies where nothing protected them at all. A couple of them started to let out screams of pain, but they didn't have time to do so before bullets ripped through the gaps between their helmets and necks. Even their SWAT-style armor failed to protect their heads, and they fell over dead, blood oozing out of tens of holes littered across their bodies.

In just under ten seconds, Ose wiped the humans out without even bothering to use her lightning. She grinned even more creepily at the sight of those pathetic humans collapsing onto their fronts and backs, never to move again.

"Mere bullets. Even if I wasn't deliberating slapping them away, they'd barely hurt me. You humans are ignorant; deliberately kept that way by the powers that be. To avoid panic, they tie the arms of their 'brave' men and women behind their backs. It would be sad if it wasn't so hilarious! Hahahaha!"

Ose stomped her foot. She sent a thunderclap blasting down the halls as if it were a seismic charge, shattering the eardrums of any human within a thousand meters. Hundreds of soldiers and civilians collapsed to their knees or instantly fell unconscious from the pain. Ose strolled past mountains of unmoving bodies, not even deigning to finish them off.

She was a Demon Emperor now. When she was a Baron, small arms fire had a real chance to kill her. That threat no longer existed. Humans simply lacked weaponry effective enough to stop her.

If Ose was a demon like Diablo, then she would still need to worry about heavy arms fire, such as anti-tank rifles, missiles, artillery shells, and so on. Diablo was not particularly resilient. A well-placed shot could instantly kill him if it struck his head. Whether he remained *dead* or turned into the Archdemon was another issue entirely.

Ose did not have this weakness. Her body was just as hardy as Diablo's, but her reaction time and movement speed completely outclassed every other Emperor. Bullets posed little to no threat to her, since she could watch them crawl toward her and smack them aside with relative ease. Missiles were faster and scarier, but she was underground now and short of a bunker-buster, the humans couldn't hit her with those. The same was true of tanks. In these cramped underground hallways, they simply didn't have the means to stop her.

Even if she were out in the open, Ose wasn't worried. She had a bigger advantage outside, because she could instantly zip away at the speed of light. Short of a sneak attack somehow catching her off-guard, the humans had no counter to her abilities.

She knew for a fact this would not be the case forever. They were sure to start developing counters to her Threat, and the two Trueborn were always a little worrying, but those two simply hadn't had enough time to properly assess her abilities. As long as she got what she came for, she was certain to be the biggest winner of this sudden decapitation strike.

It has to be here. Ose thought, her eyes flickering as she used the sonar pulse caused by her thunder-stomp to map out the halls around herself. Indeed, she had not thundered through the base to incapacitate the humans, though that *had* been a nice side-effect, but rather to map out these underground hallways. Even with her formidable hacking skills, Ose wasn't 100% certain of the direction to her destination.

The base momentarily fell completely silent. Ose ran forward at several hundred miles an hour, her body leaving afterimages as she screamed down the hallways at speeds that would leave a formula racer's eyes watering. She looked left and she looked right, eventually arriving at a blast door leading to Level 4. She bashed it inward with a few well-placed punches, only for a hail of bullets to fire at her from the darkness ahead.

"This again? You're all so predictable." Ose muttered, starting to feel a little bored. She couldn't help herself. It was fun stomping weaklings for a short while, but she was already craving a sense of novelty these ordinary humans couldn't provide.

Just as Ose once again swatted the bullets away, her heart skipped a beat. A steel net flew at her, mixed with the bullets. Due to its extremely thin wires and the darkness behind it, she failed to notice it in time.

Thwip!

The net tangled around Ose's arm, and then her body. She cried out in anger as it enveloped her body and sent her tumbling backward where she landed on her ass.

"You fucking HUMANS!!" Ose screeched. "Nice trick! Too bad that's all it was!!"

In an instant, her Tertiary Mind Realm, existing at 10,000x normalspeed, came up with a counter. She agitated the molecules on her skin, raising her surface body temperature to over a thousand degrees!

The wire, while strong and resistant to tearing, proved incapable of resisting the intense heat. She melted it to slag, unfortunately also burning her clothes away and leaving her naked. Humiliated, Ose jumped to her feet, ignoring the glorious sight she was revealing to the few remaining humans up ahead. It's not like they were going to live long enough to enjoy it.

"You fuckers! You made me ruin my clothes! Do you think a tailored suit comes CHEAP?!"

Ose rocketed forward and lifted her leg. She swept it down in an axe kick and struck the floor, blasting lightning and a thunderous shockwave outward in all directions. She obliterated the bodies of the nearby humans, cursing them for forcing her to walk around in her birthday suit.

"Perverts! Despicable scoundrels! When I eradicate the human race, I'll only regret how much time it took me to succeed!"

Ose deliberately agitated as much lightning around herself as she could to obscure her body. The storm of light that engulfed her paradoxically made her easier to see, but also made it impossible to look directly at her without blinding any eyes or cameras that did.

If she had been the Ose of Jason's time, she might have chuckled a little at going through an unfortunate fiasco that Beelzebub did, time and time again. The number of

times he'd scorched his clothes to ash and ended up standing around buck-naked must have been in the hundreds...

But this Ose had no sense of humor; only malice and rage. She didn't find her current predicament amusing in the slightest.

She picked up the pace. The blast doors to floors 6, 7, 8 and 9 posed her no problems. All the while, the commanders holed up on the southern edge of Floor 10 were practically shitting bricks.

"I thought you said the first reinforcements had arrived already? Where are they?!" Commander Robert roared.

"I don't know, sir! Maybe they're still trying to catch up from behind. The Entity is extremely agile. She's difficult to pin down!"

"We're dead! There's no way we stand a chance once she makes it to us!"

The commanding officers were all brave men and women, and they had pledged their lives to the military. Even so, dying in honorable battle when they were younger was very different from being slaughtered like pigs in their advanced age. They all wanted to live to retirement and enjoy their days in a nice beach-house somewhere.

"Commander Robert! The Entity has arrived on Floor 10! She's here!"

"No... something's not right... she isn't heading for the Command Center... she's heading for... huh?"

Robert looked at the map of the base in disbelief. Ose entered from the west and headed in the opposite direction from the Command Center, which was located at the southern edge of Floor 10. Instead, she headed toward the northern wing.

"Could it be?" Robert muttered. "She's going... *there*? But why?"

Ose's heart raced with excitement. She was close. So very very close! Her destination was in sight!

She arrived inside the start of the lower underground levels, and the place where she finally entered a massive underground facility. Unlike the floors above, Floor 10 was hundreds of feet tall because it had to house Area 51's most precious asset...

The Crashed Ship.

It was alien in design. Ose knew that the moment she stepped into the hangar and laid eyes on it. Its exterior was too smooth to be human-made. It was shaped like a bullet, but it had visible damage all over its surface; made more obvious because of all the dings, dents, and scratches to its otherwise flawless silvery exterior.

"Hahaha! There you are, my precious baby! And your cargo... I'll be taking it!"

Ose's eyes flashed with energy. She rocketed to the ship and kicked the ground, killing hundreds of humans who were hiding in the nearby area. She didn't only kill them for sport, but also because they might have a chance to see her pristine body if they squinted hard enough, and that was unacceptable!

She entered the wrecked ship. It wasn't large, barely big enough to house a half-dozen human-sized entities. There were living quarters, a sleeping area with pods of some sort, and...

Ose looked left. She looked right. She entered the cockpit, taking a moment to familiarize herself with the strange, alien symbols.

"I knew there was life beyond the Earth. That much was made obvious by the existence of the Angels. But this... this technology is even more advanced than I expected. How has the government managed to keep this ship's details under wraps? And most importantly, WHERE IS IT??"

A tingling sensation tickled the back of Ose's mind. She reached out to send her electrical powers into the ship, forcibly energizing its power core. It turned on and started speaking in an alien language.

"**Ensa' sha lattlh'ata su ianftuthk La'aftt Ona sh'uiagh Th'aa luftus thuns'uftt.**"

Ose blinked. She had absolutely no idea what the computerized voice was saying.

"Hmm. That sentence was rather strange. Let's see if I can analyze it..."

Her Tertiary Brain flared up with activity. Operating at 10,000x normalspeed, it rapidly analyzed the speech and vocal patterns of the alien computer. In less than five seconds, Ose managed to decrypt what it was saying.

"**Enter the passphrase to unlock Levels One through Three pilot controls.**"

Ose spoke in a language identical to the ship, though much less guttural and noticeably more silky-smooth, as she was unable to perfectly replicate the harsh growls

and consonants.

"Where... is... the mainframe... the brain? Where is... the artificial core to this ship?" She asked.

"**Enter the passphrase to unlock Levels One through Three pilot controls.**" The ship repeated.

Ose's expression turned to a scowl. She had no idea what the passphrase was, and it seemed the ship wasn't going to tell her. However, by cycling her electrical power through the ship's conduits, she noticed something important.

"There! That must be where the artificial intelligence core is supposed to be located.. but it's empty! Why isn't it here? Did the humans remove it?"

Realizing the AI core wasn't where she thought it would be, Ose immediately lost interest in the ship. It certainly had research potential, but that didn't matter to her half as much as obtaining the real treasure of this journey.

She exited the craft and looked around. Amidst all the bodies of exploded and burned humans, she spotted a few different rooms on the far wall. One of them was wide open, its doors having unfortunately jammed when the base went into lockdown. She instantly noticed that a larger number of dead humans were lying nearer to that door than the others.

Ose flickered over to the entrance. She looked inside and saw, amidst the darkness, a towering glass cage currently powered off. There were many cables leading into it, clearly needed to pump a colossal amount of power from the local Nevada grid into what she immediately realized was the AI core of the ship.

"Jackpot." Ose said, grinning like a madwoman.

She stormed into the room and sent a pulse of electricity at the wall. The lights turned on, and she finally got a good look at the tall glass cylinder housing her precious treasure.

Her grin vanished.

"What? Empty? How can it be empty? The core isn't here? Did the humans anticipate my true purpose? Did they hide it somewhere so I couldn't steal it for myself?"

Just as Ose became momentarily baffled, the door leading into the AI core room loudly clanged shut. Its two blast doors crashed together and made her jump slightly.

Ose turned around. She raised an eyebrow, seeing she had been sealed inside.

"Oh? What's this? The humans are trying to trap me?"

She snorted derisively. Then she flickered at the door and pulled her left fist back. She rushed at the door full-speed.

BOOOM!!

Ose punched the door with all her might. She unleashed a megaton of energy to empower her fist and blasted the door with all the same gusto she had those blast doors earlier.

The instant her fist made contact with the metal, she realized things were not as they seemed.

Her finger bones shattered. Her wrist buckled. A lightning burst of pain shot up her arm and rocked her body.

"AAARGH!"

Her arm practically shattered on impact. Its bones snapped and exploded in multiple places. Blood erupted in all directions, soaking her nude body and the nearby walls and ground with liquid plasma.

The door didn't even vibrate.

"Ahh! Ahhh!" Ose cried, tears welling up in her eyes. She was hurt so badly that for a moment, she nearly blacked out. Her Tertiary brain quickly took over, suppressing all her pain signals and firing an adrenaline burst back into her mind, keeping her awake.

Caught in a cold sweat, Ose stumbled backward. Her arm throbbed agonizingly, and even with her pain senses dulled, she still wanted to cry like a little girl.

She gingerly held her shattered arm. Blood had coated her from head to toe, and she shivered from pain.

"What... what the fuck..." Ose whispered, her pupils contracting and expanding as she stared at the door in horror. "What is this alloy? It's... I didn't even leave a dent... my arm... oh Seven Hells, my *devil-damned* arm..."

At that moment, a male voice spoke from behind her.

"Hey Ose. Looks like you fell for it."

Ose's heart turned cold. She whirled around to find a familiar man standing behind her. His arms were crossed. He wore a nekomimi mask with a neutral expression on its face.

Cat Mask grinned evilly at Ose from beneath his mask. She couldn't see his expression... but she could feel it.

"Hahaha." Cat Mask laughed coldly. "Nice tits and ass. I love that you're giving me a peep show before I kill you."

Ose trembled. She quickly ignited her electrical power to try and cover her body, but she knew it didn't matter. Cat Mask had already gotten an eyeful, and that was *unforgiveable*.

"You... this was all... a trap?" Ose hissed woozily.

"Duh. Honestly, I thought we made it too easy. You didn't even notice most of the 'humans' you killed were just a bunch of soulless meat puppets." Cat Mask taunted. "A few had to die to maintain the illusion, but... ah, what does it matter? There's no use telling you when you're about to die anyway."

Cat Mask casually reached into the sheathes at his side. He pulled out a pair of deceptively simple-looking knives. Ose's pupils shrank and expanded. She was not in good condition. Her body was still wracked with pain. Her breathing was labored. And Cat Mask seemed... different. He must have taken into account her abilities... could he have determined a way to kill her?

If she was fresh and hadn't shattered her damn arm, Ose was 95% certain she would mop the floor with Cat Mask like she did at the Illuminati Base. His defensive wards wouldn't protect him from her Emperor-level attacks. She would definitely win.

But now?

Ose stopped trembling. Her mind sharpened as she released a hideous smile.

"Hehehe... a good trick. A good trap! I can't help but respect someone who's able to pull one over on me. But my accidental handicap won't save you, Cat Mask. I'm going to kill you, then I'm going to find out where you hid that AI core, then I'm going to kill your son, too. *Not necessarily in that order*."

Cat Mask snorted. "You ain't doing *shit*."

Part 672: Emperor Ose VS Cat Mask

Recommended Listening

January 29th, 2021. Area 51, Nevada.

Despite being badly injured, it was Ose who attacked first, not Cat Mask. Desperate to reverse her sudden unfortunate situation, Ose snapped forward at Hideki and sent a hurricane kick firing at his face. Cat Mask bent over backward with unnatural agility, causing her leg to sweep over his mask, missing it by a millimeter. She followed up with a flurry of kicks, spins, and flips, sometimes using her one good arm to spin on as she revolved her legs overhead.

Cat Mask's body blurred occasionally. He moved with far more fluidity than he did before; a result of Jason's magical augmentations. Finally, Cat Mask's body was able to keep up with his cerebral speeds a bit better than before.

From his point of view, Ose's legs were a blur. Even after slowing his perception of time to a crawl, his body was sluggish and unable to keep up with hers. Her physical parameters had shot way up after becoming an Emperor. She had already taken him apart when she was a Baron, and her physical speed was even more frightening now.

But Cat Mask was unworried.

"You have a nice ass, Ose!" He shouted, turning her face beet-red. "What a fine pair of plump tomatoes you've been hiding under that tight-white suit! A man could really get used to a sight like this!"

"SHUT YOUR MOUTH!!" Ose shrieked. Electricity blasted out of her body and struck Hideki, knocking him back a little and numbing his body for a moment. Luckily, the Wordsmithed enchantments kept him from falling over and deflected most of the damage.

With her legs finding no purchase, Ose suddenly reversed tactics. She hopped off her hand, spun in midair, and landed on her feet. Her agility was catlike, well beyond what most Emperors could achieve. She instantly conjured a sword made of lightning, and her arm started furiously whipping around as she chased after Hideki.

Cat Mask was not as fast as Ose. He wasn't even in the same league. Because of his ability to slow down his perception of time, he was able to brute-force predicting her attacks, but she was actually so fast with her near-instantaneous movements that he rapidly began losing his ability to keep up.

It started subtly. The edge of her sword barely cut the edge of his shirt. A stray arc of electricity landed on his elbow.

But she rapidly gained an advantage. Even when Cat Mask's body blurred as he rewound time to retry a movement here or there, he quickly found he was unable to dodge all of her attacks.

From Ose's perspective, Cat Mask seemed relatively fast, but she also recognized that he was not truly able to keep up with her. She could react instantly to any stimuli, but he still needed to 'perceive' things before he could react. This subtle difference was something she recognized and sought to exploit.

Cat Mask swiped a knife at Ose. She handily ducked the attack and rammed her elbow into his ribs, eliciting a weak grunt of pain from him. Then she spun on her heel to try and sweep his legs, but he hopped in the air at the last second.

"Seems Mildred gave you another power-up. But that won't matter!" Ose taunted. "You're slowing down the more we fight! Even while I'm maimed, I'm more than your match!"

Ose's baseline endurance level was far above Hideki's. Every whiffed punch left him open for a counter, while she recovered with ease. In the end, he might be a human with billions of years of training, but he was still only an ordinary man. Hardening his bones and accelerating his mental state along with his body's speed did not come close to narrowing the gap between him and a Demon Emperor.

But Hideki did have one advantage. He was stronger than Ose, if only by a little. His punches hit harder, his grip strength surpassed hers, and his body's Wordsmithed defenses were higher too.

It was an even fight. Neither side had the obvious advantage.

Ose was wracked with pain from her limply hanging arm. With no time offered to bandage it up or tourniquet the wound, she could feel herself weakening over time, pain interspersed with the blows she rained on Hideki. Every violent flip of her legs or flicker

of her body sent her dangling arm slapping around, which made her grit her teeth and hiss in pain.

After five minutes, Hideki was winded and tired by a level that was starting to affect his fighting capabilities. Constantly trying to avoid Ose's attacks was mentally draining. The lightning that managed to hit him left his hair frazzled and his nerves taut. Ose was in agony, but Hideki was definitely the one feeling most bruised by their battle.

Ose reared her fist back again, but Hideki abruptly vanished from the spot, teleporting away. He'd done this several times, so Ose quickly went on the defensive, flicking her eyes to look around for him.

He didn't reappear.

Still, she kept her guard up. She finally took a few seconds to hurriedly cradle her injured arm while looking around the room for something, anything, that she could use as a tourniquet. She spotted some wires on the wall and her eyes flashed. She zipped over and ripped them out while hurriedly using her teeth and still-functioning right arm to bind her wound just below the shoulder. She whipped up a crappy makeshift sling and bound her useless arm under her breasts, then looked around again.

Hideki still hadn't returned. He'd been gone for thirty seconds, which was the longest delay in their fight so far.

Just when Ose started to wonder what trick he would play, Hideki reappeared. He no longer looked winded or tired. In fact, he seemed as if he'd taken a power nap for an hour. He was dancing lightly on his feet once more while smiling at her beneath his mask.

"Ah, you made a sling faster than I thought you would." Hideki teased. "Guess I took too long returning. Oh well. I was starting to feel bad for you, seeing that useless thing flap around."

Ose looked at him with slightly dazed eyes. How did he suddenly appear so refreshed? Where did he go for those thirty seconds?

For the first time, Ose was feeling a little nervous. Five minutes of furious fighting wasn't anything much, but she was literally naked and didn't have access to her arsenal of gadgets. She had assumed that even if the humans tried to trap her, they would fail. She was more than strong enough to rip her way out of an underground vault formed entirely

out of tungsten and reinforced steel, but she had no way of anticipating the weird alloy forming the internals of this AI lab.

"What are you playing at?" Ose asked, narrowing her eyes. "You think you can kill me?"

"Honestly, it's been harder than I expected." Hideki admitted. "You're one tough cunt, I'll give you that much. You're the biggest challenge I've faced in several eons. If I'd known you were this tough as an Emperor, I would have tried to uplift you a long time ago."

"What does that mean? What are you even saying?" Ose asked, more confused than anything. "You're a battle maniac? You like fighting?"

"Nothing as boring as that." Hideki said, resting a hand on his waist. He took a moment to drink in the fine, fine appearance of Ose's nude body. As for the Emperor herself, she was just glad to have a few seconds to catch her breath. "I've experienced so many sights, so many sounds, so many of the same days, nothing excites me anymore. I've started to think this recent change in my life isn't as bad as I previously thought. All my plans are falling apart, but instead of despair I feel only relief. I don't have to go at this all alone anymore. I get to experience a fresh start!"

Ose stared at him in bewilderment as if he were a babbling madman. What the hell was he even talking about? He sounded like a man so old even Raphael would have to call him 'grandpa', but that was an absurd thought. The oldest human was born less than a hundred thousand years ago!

"A fresh start?" Ose repeated. She analyzed his words at insane speeds inside her tertiary brain. A lot of alarming possibilities came to mind, but the data seemed garbled. She was missing key information. "What do you mean by that?"

Cat Mask's body momentarily blurred. He seemed to do that a lot, Ose noted. She felt that understanding his body-blur was key to unlocking the secrets of the masked man, but she needed more information.

When he stopped blurring, Cat Mask chuckled. "God. You really are an impressive woman. You always manage to figure it out within the next thirty or so minutes. I don't know why I never noticed until the Shattering, but you are without a doubt one of, if not *the* most intelligent person on Earth. Maybe ascending to Emperor was the key to unlocking the potential I missed in you before."

"Enough with your riddles!" Ose shouted. She was starting to feel deeply uneasy. "If you're going to kill me, then just do it! Or are you scared I'll take you down with me?!"

Cat Mask didn't answer. He simply stared at her, as if uncertain what to say. Or maybe he liked how the silence was just as taunting as his words.

Ose's pupils shrunk. She launched at Cat Mask and sent a fist flying at his face.

"Oraaaa!!"

She expected him to dodge like he had before, but her heart nearly jumped out of her chest when he didn't move. He didn't even twitch his body!

THWACK!

Her fist crashed against his mask at full power and sent the man flying. He slammed against the far wall with a thunderous crash! Ose's jaw practically fell to the ground. Why the hell didn't he dodge? Did he suddenly have a death wish?!

She took a step forward, half wanting to rush over and finish him off, and half uncertain if this was some greater trick he was trying to pull. Was he a madman? Literally insane?

Cat Mask's body shuddered. He climbed to his feet. Then he turned and looked at Ose.

His mask was gone. Shattered into a thousand pieces. His face was bleeding a little, but otherwise it seemed his defensive wards were more than enough to resist her hasty strike.

"You!" Ose exclaimed, shocked by his true appearance. He was a Japanese man. His face had a faint smile, but most importantly...

Ose squinted at him.

"...Who the bloody hell ARE you? I thought with the way you were talking I'd know you, but I've never seen you in my life!"

"Not this life." Hideki said, chuckling under his breath. "You've seen my face before. Lots of times, actually. You just don't remember them."

Ose's expression became more puzzled than before, then it slowly changed as she began to put some pieces together.

"Wait. You..."

"That's the amazing thing about you, Ose." Hideki said, casually stuffing his hands into his pockets. "You always figure it out. Even if I give you no hints, you uncover the secret to my power. I've been tempted to go back further and prevent your ascension to Emperor, but... I sort of don't *care* anymore. It doesn't matter if you know. It doesn't matter if *anyone* knows."

Ose's heart skipped a beat.

"Time manipulation." She said quietly.

Hideki rolled his eyes. "I made it too easy this time. Whatever. You should feel proud though, since you figured it all out within an hour of furious combat the first time we fought. I tried to be sneaky, but only managed to fool you for two hours the next time. Then one and a half the time after that. Then two and a half, one hour, thirty minutes, two hours..."

He shook his head and looked off to the side.

"I'll spare you the deductive work. Maybe this time will turn out different if I just lay it all on the table."

Cat Mask held up three fingers.

"My first ability is time rewinding."

"My second ability is time deceleration."

"My third ability is my perfect eidetic memory."

He shrugged, then tossed his hands in the air. "See? Isn't that fun? Now we can fight at our full potential. I know all your abilities, and you know all mine. Ah, right, I'm also super strong and hardy because of some external boons placed upon my body, but that's neither here nor there. You already guessed that much."

Ose's brain moved at lightning speeds. She instantly deduced that he wasn't lying, and that his powers had all kinds of up and downstream effects she needed to consider.

"You can rewind time?" Ose asked incredulously. "How many times have you done so?"

Hideki merely cocked his head, raised an eyebrow, and smirked. He didn't answer.

"There's no limit? So that means you just keep going back again and again and *again* until you achieve your objectives." Ose analyzed. "Which means you've probably fought

me tens, hundreds, even thousands of times. You've probably coaxed every ability you can out of me. You know all my hidden trump cards."

"Yeah. I do." Hideki said. "So, you can go ahead and drop the act. Heal that arm up. It just isn't any fun fighting you when you're in this weakened state."

Ose's stomach fell. She had been hoping to trick him, wait for the opportune moment, and land a killing blow, but if he said that, then he truly had to be a rewinding-type Hero.

"I will say this though." Hideki added. "I *love* fighting you. Your body is truly fine. You keep in shape. You've got nice tits, a nice ass, even that belly..."

Ose lurched backward. She looked at him in disgust. "You... pig! Have you defiled me in those alternate timelines?"

"What? No. I'm not a goddamn monster." Hideki said, before looking away and coughing. "Though I did set up that net trap to get you out of those clothes. It's led to a huge improvement over our first battles."

Ose wanted to wretch. This human was sick in the head. He was a creep, a pervert, and even more worryingly, an unstoppable nightmare. She didn't know how she could possibly beat him. If he wasn't lying, and if his abilities were what he said they were, then he'd probably sussed out every conceivable-

"Come on, already." Hideki said impatiently. "Just switch to that Thunder God Form. I haven't even started to enjoy myself yet. I'm hoping for a new restore point I can keep going back to."

Ose's expression turned dismal. "Two hypotheses come to mind. Either you're trying to break my spirit so you can kill me more easily, or you're hoping to finish me off at my best so you can get off on the thrill."

"Eh." Hideki grunted, shrugging lightly. "I mean kinda neither, kinda both? How do you know I haven't already killed you a bunch of times and just kept coming back because it would be a shame to put an end to that sexy, curvaceous ass?"

Ose's eyes bloomed with rage. She roared with a primal fury and tapped into her inner wellspring of power. Electrical energy exploded around her body, swallowed her skin and bones, and rapidly turned her into a glowing entity made of plasma and electricity.

The Thunder God Form which she had used against Belial in the far future had now made its return, but Ose didn't feel triumphant in the slightest. All she would be doing

was giving battle data about this form to Hideki, ensuring he could defeat her even more handily on the next loop.

Was there some way she could kill him? Could she land some sort of a sneak attack to-

"Nope." Hideki said, interrupting Ose's thoughts. "I'm unkillable. It's my secret fourth ability. If anything is about to kill me, time completely stops. Then I can rewind until I escape the danger. Truth be told, I've already seen the entire Earth fall to those aliens who made that escape pod out there. They're called Volgrim, by the way. Not nice people. Kinda bastards, if I'm being honest."

"Are you reading my thoughts?!" Ose asked.

"Nah. But I can tell what you're thinking just by the way your eyes move. We've spent a *lot* of time together. Plus you tried tricking me into telling you if there was some way to kill me on a few previous loops. I lied, you tried the method, it failed. I laughed. Good times."

Ose seriously wanted to rip her hair out! Cat Mask was infuriating to a degree she couldn't remember ever previously experiencing. She even thought he might be more annoying than Bael, as crazy as that thought was!

"So what now?" Ose asked. "We fight?"

Her left arm had turned into pure energy and fully reformed. If she left the Thunder God state, she would be back in prime fighting shape. A little tired from the massive amount of energy needed to fight, but still in much better condition than she was at the start.

Hideki fell silent. After a moment, his body blurred. He gave her a weird look, then shook his head.

"Alright. I'm officially not having fun anymore. You know what? You can go, Ose. I've held you here long enough."

Ose blinked. They hadn't even fought yet, and he was already giving up??

Or was it that when his body blurred, that meant he's just rewound time? If so, did they already fight? What happened in those alternate futures? How many times had he rewound???

"You couldn't kill me, so you're giving up?" Ose asked.

"Huh? Oh, nothing like that. I killed you a bunch of times." Hideki said, shrugging nonchalantly. "But it just... it didn't feel *right* to me. I'm sure from your perspective this is all rather confusing, but I've grown to admire you so much, I just can't bring myself to finish the job. So I'll leave you to my son instead. If he can kill you, then so be it. If not, then that's fine too."

Hideki turned around, as if to leave, but Ose's eyes narrowed.

"Wait!" She shouted.

Hideki paused. He looked back at her. "What?"

"That's it?" She asked. "You're letting me live? Why? Are you stupid?"

"I don't know why..." Hideki said, his gaze turning odd. "I don't think I can put this feeling into words."

His shoulders sagged a little. He looked off into the distance.

"I'm lonely, Ose. Nobody understands the life I've lived. Nobody can. I don't view people as 'people' anymore. They're more like... NPCs in a video game. They give preset replies to questions, as if they were being manipulated by the hand of an invisible puppeteer."

He closed his eyes.

"I've watched the Earth burn. A thousand times. A million times. I stopped caring whether it survived or was destroyed a long time ago. I lived for my obsession. I planned every single action out. I created the 'perfect' script that would set a future into motion according to my whims. I was ready to finally end it all. Let myself die by not rewinding time, and instead allowing my death to occur."

Hideki shook his head.

"But then everything changed. Nothing stayed the same. All my meticulous plans collapsed. I was left with the shadowy remnants of that 'obsession' plaguing my mind, asking myself, 'did it even matter' and 'why did I ever care'?"

Ose stared at the side of Hideki's face. Slowly, she removed her Thunder God Form, returning to her original body.

Hideki glanced at her. He smiled, but the expression was lifeless and empty.

"While I was fighting you, I felt something I hadn't felt in a long time. A spark of joy. Excitement. *Fun*. Yeah. It's *fun* fighting you, talking to you, learning from you. You don't have any way to know this, but my combat capabilities before I fought you the first time versus this very moment are lightyears apart. I've mastered all my 'boons'. I can fight at my peak level for way longer. I can anticipate all your attacks before you even know you're making them."

Ose felt a chill go down her bones. She hoped Hideki was bluffing, because that meant if they did end up fighting, she would definitely lose.

Hideki walked toward Ose. She took a step back, then another step, eyeing him like a rabbit would eye a tiger. She suddenly realized that she was feeling *fear*. Since when did the great Ose experience such an emotion as fear?!

Ose gritted her teeth. With her body made whole, she was close to her peak physical condition. She sent a punch flying at Hideki, but he casually stepped aside, grabbed her wrist, and spun her around. Ose yelped in fright as he twisted her arm behind her back and slammed her against the wall while pressing his body against hers.

"Agh! Unhand me!!" Ose yelled. She tried to punch him, kick him, anything to free herself, but two carefully aimed punches struck her kidney and lung, knocking the wind out of her. Hideki pressed her even more forcefully against the wall, leaving her shivering in terror.

He wasn't bluffing. He was way stronger than her! She didn't have a chance!

"Sorry." Hideki said, after holding her there for a few moments. He released his grip on her wrists and dropped her to the ground. Ose scurried backward, looking up at him with terror-filled eyes.

"I like fighting you. But I don't like hurting you anymore." Hideki said quietly. He looked at the ground and shuffled his feet. "I've seen how evil you can be... but I've also seen that you're not as corrupted as you think. There's still some good in you."

Ose rubbed her wrist. "Are... are you making a pass at me? Have you developed feelings for me, or something?!"

"Feelings." Hideki repeated. He looked at her with a strange gaze. "I thought I lost those at some point, eons in the past. Maybe you're right. I know you don't feel anything

for me, though. It's purely one-sided on my end. Maybe that's why I can't bring myself to kill you. I'd rather break down the walls you surround yourself with."

Hideki pursed his lips.

"What made you this way, Ose?"

Ose met Hideki's eyes. There was neither warmth nor coldness in them. Rather, they seemed... empty. Hollow. As if he no longer knew how to feel about anything.

"*What made me this way?*" Ose repeated.

"No. Stop. Don't tell me." Hideki said, quickly turning away. "Save it for our next meeting."

He turned and walked away. Just before he teleported out of the chamber, he sent one last glance back Ose's way.

"I hope you won't force me to rewind again, Ose. Consider what we've discussed carefully."

He vanished, leaving the room silent and empty, with only Ose breathing quietly by herself.

After a full minute of silence, Ose jumped to her feet. She blinked her eyes and looked around as if in a daze.

"That was..."

"That was a REALLY weird encounter!" She spat into the void. "Creep! Sex-pest! Pervert!"

Part 673: Father, Why?

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

"Dad, what the FUCK? What were you thinking?!"

Jason and Hideki met in the eastern side of the city of Argent, but they were not there to sight-see. Jason's eyes locked onto his father's, flames practically billowing from his nostrils.

"She's Ose! OSE! One of, if not THE most dangerous of all the Demon Emperors! Why didn't you kill her? Why did you act all weird and shit, then let her go??"

Jason threw his hands in the air. He stomped his feet. He was enraged more than at any point in recent memory. Ose wasn't merely a dangerous enemy; she was also someone who had, at least in theory, taken actions that killed Jason's daughter. Daisy survived Beelzebub's detonation, true, but that was neither here nor there. Millions of humans still ended up dead as a result of Stormbringer.

Hideki was unmoved. "Sorry, son, but you're overthinking it. I'm not killing her. Do it yourself if you want her dead that badly."

"And how do I know you won't just rewind time and save her life?" Jason retorted. "This is so fucked up! What, just because you think she's hot, you're using your dick instead of your head??"

Before Hideki could interrupt, Jason threw something else out there. "And what about my MOM?! I thought she was your soul-mate! I thought she was the only woman you'd ever love!"

For a brief moment, Hideki didn't reply.

"...I was wrong." He eventually said, his voice low. "I rewound time on many different occasions to travel back and be with Olivia again. But ultimately, the relationship couldn't last. If I got Olivia pregnant, she'd give birth to you and die. Without fail."

He continued. "You're also forgetting something, Jason. I can't go back and see her ever again. I've lost that ability. I can only rewind to the point right after the timelines shattered, when you regained your memories of the future. So... even if I wanted to remain faithful to your mother, there's no point."

Hideki looked off to the side and crossed his arms.

"Olivia is dead. For good. It's time I moved on."

"That's it?" Jason asked. "You can't see her anymore, so you're just going to move on?"

Hideki quietly sighed and rolled his eyes.

"You're a three-dimensional thinker, so I can't *entirely* blame you. But use your head, Jason. How often do men lose their wives and then remarry within a few years? How long is it considered acceptable to remain single before a man moves on? What, two years? Five years? Ten? Twenty?"

He gave his son a long look.

"I haven't been with your mother in ages, Jason. I already hadn't visited her in an eon or two and that was before I couldn't rewind all the way back to see her again. Extracting you from the Illuminati's base probably took me a few millennia alone. Do you have the slightest idea, even with my reduced ability to rewind, how many temporal years I've experienced since then? *Hundreds of thousands of years*."

Jason's anger became somewhat muted. "It's... been that long for you?"

"You cannot begin to fathom my conceptualization of time." Hideki flatly stated. "I was faithful for a plenty long time. Now I'm moving on. You'll just have to deal with it."

"If you want to move on, then move on. I can accept that." Jason said. "But not with Ose! NOT Ose! She's a goddamn Demon Emperor, dad! And not just any Emperor, but one of the most vicious and cruel ones!"

"Doesn't matter to me." Hideki said with a shrug. "If push comes to shove, I'll bite the bullet, go back, and admit you were right. But you're not. You don't know her like I do. I spent a lot of time with her in Area 51. I even managed to pry a little bit of information out of her on a few occasions, though her emotions are well-hidden behind a wall."

Hideki's nostrils flared. He smiled cheekily.

"But that's what makes it fun. Conquering a woman who might never accept me! Not like Olivia, who just went along with whatever I wanted. That kind of woman has her own charm, but Ose appeals to my base, filthy animal instincts. You see, son, a man like me has sexual needs beyond that of an ordinary-"

"I've heard enough." Jason quickly interrupted, turning away from Hideki. "Fine. Do what you want. It's not like I'll remember this conversation when you rewind anyway."

Jason paused. He glanced back at his father.

"If you want to get your tip wet, that's *whatever*, but why did you have to tell her about your powers? About all that other stuff? You gave her way too much information!"

"Ose's a smart woman." Hideki said, nibbling his lip longingly. "The way her mind works fascinates me. Her analytical and deductive abilities are superior even to my own. I'm an old dog that hates learning new tricks, but she's a voracious student. She's constantly learning, adapting to new stimuli... being around her makes me feel young again."

Jason scowled. It's not like he couldn't understand that Ose was an extremely attractive demoness. Hell, she had white hair, and after the years Jason had spent with Phoebe and Fiona, that particular color definitely elicited a faint animal yearning in the back of his lizard brain...

But Ose was pure evil. He would never believe that she was capable of changing. He just hoped that his father would ultimately rewind, undo the damage, and kill her. Jason had no way of knowing if or when that would happen though, so he'd have to come up with his own way of killing her.

"Jason, I can see that you're still unsatisfied." Hideki said. "But you're not looking at this the right way. What if you turned Ose from your enemy into your ally? Don't you think having a genius like her on your side could drastically elevate Earth's future battle strength?"

"Of course I've considered that option." Jason retorted. "But that's a god-damn big 'if', dad. She's scarily smart *and* a schemer. She could pretend to be my ally only to backstab me at the absolute worst opportunity. Better to take her out and choose a more reliable option."

"Like who? Marie Becker?" Hideki asked. He scoffed. "She is absolutely a super-genius, but a different type compared to Ose. More importantly, Marie Becker has something important she needs to do. Her role in the future war is exceedingly complicated. It would be pure idiocy to pull her away to work on whatever you think is more important."

Jason smirked. "I wasn't thinking of Marie at all, dad. I was thinking of *Nadia*. My daughter's friend seems to have an incredible cerebral power on par with Solomon. Once I pair her with the proper MindCore, I think she'll become one of Earth's key figures."

Jason was actually a little surprised his father didn't already think of Nadia. Maybe Hideki was only having this conversation for the first time and hadn't rewound yet. He'd probably bring up Nadia on the next rewind and throw Jason off. The absolute bastard.

"Nadia. Hmm." Hideki grunted.

"What? You know about her?" Jason asked.

"Only a little. I spoke to just about everyone on Earth at some point in my life. That doesn't mean we had detailed conversations. I don't know literally everything about everyone, but I did save the faces and names of every person in my Crown Core. Nadia... was never an impressive figure."

"Did she have a magical ability in the previous timelines, before Daisy's arrival?" Jason asked.

"No..." Hideki said slowly. "Almost nobody did. We had a couple Lowborn Heroes that arose as a result of my presence, but your daughter makes them sprout up like weeds. And since the timeline shattered when you regained your memories, I don't actually know what future we'll be entering and who all these new actors will turn out to be."

Hideki looked a little worried, but also relieved. "I don't know what's coming up, which makes me anxious, but at the same time... it's out of my hands now! This future is yours to seize, son. I'm just coming along for the ride."

Jason sighed. His anger deflated, and he shook his head. "Just don't go overboard with Ose, dad. You know what they say about not sticking your dick in crazy... and she's batshit insane."

Hideki ruffled Jason's hair. Then he turned to leave. But before he disappeared, he chuckled.

"By the way, Jason? If you died tomorrow, the abilities you've given me, particularly the ability to teleport using Aevum's inexhaustible power source... if I had that in the original timeline, humanity might not have lost the war. You really underestimate just how incredible planet or even galaxy-wide teleportation is to a rewinder like me."

Jason blinked. He nodded at the back of his father's head.

"Huh. I hadn't really thought of it like that, but yeah. You can just go wherever you want, investigate any situation, and if you get caught you can simply rewind time and go somewhere else."

"If only you knew how much I've been abusing this new power." Hideki said with a chuckle.

He teleported away, leaving Jason alone.

Ose glowered at the door leading out of the AI Core room. By now, she had tried breaking past countless different points, but it seemed she had been left here by Hideki and he wasn't going to help her escape.

"What alloy is this? It seems unbreakable." Ose muttered to herself. "Nothing I throw at it leaves a scratch or a dent. If I punch it, I'll only hurt myself. How was such a material forged? Could it have been salvaged from... the *Volgrim?*"

Ose's mouth fell silent. Her dialogue shifted to her three internal brains which were housed in her Mind Realm. She deliberately accelerated all three of them to the maximum possible speed of 100,000x realtime.

Primary was the brain most suited to analyzing and engaging in social interactions, since it was typically active at 2x realspeed.

Primary: "Cat Mask confirmed the existence of aliens, and he seemed to know a lot about them. If we encounter him again, we should try to coax more detailed intel out of him."

Secondary was a combat-focused brain. It always approached information from a combative and/or reactive perspective.

Secondary: "Negative. Cat Mask is dangerous. He will not give us any additional information unless it benefits him."

Tertiary was the brain that focused on research. It preferred to focus on solid information and was generally reclusive, analyzing things from an inventor's mindset.

Tertiary: "The Volgrim are likely to have created the alloy used to construct this room, but we must not assume that is the case. It is possible Cat Mask obtained the alloy via his temporal excursions and constructed the room to trap us."

Secondary: "Whatever Cat Mask or someone else did to build this room, the truth of the matter is that we are still stuck. If we fail to escape or take too long in breaking out, we're likely to be captured *or worse* by the United States Military. We do not have long before they arrive on scene and make their way down to the tenth level."

Primary: "Can any of our known powers allow us to escape? Maybe we could use the Thunder God Form to transform into pure energy and escape through the wall circuits, or slip through a gap in the door? What about using our Astral Form to open the door from outside?"

Secondary: "Too dangerous. If we enter our Astral Form, our body will be completely defenseless. The Archseer might teleport inside and kill us where we sit. As for escaping into the wiring, it seems Cat Mask or someone else already thought to seal off all the circuitry in this area from the rest of the complex."

Tertiary: "There is another matter we should discuss. Cat Mask revealed a lot of information, and I am not certain all of it was deliberate. He stated that the timeline we are living in has abruptly deviated far beyond his original plans. Since he was deliberately rewinding to try and control the flow of the future, that means an external source caused the temporal misalignment."

Primary: "He didn't sound as if he were attempting to deceive us. Thus, we must conclude that his words were truthful. What external event could have 'shattered' the timeline, as he put it?"

Secondary: "The question is not 'what' but 'who.' The Archseer is extremely suspicious. He claims to possess precognitive abilities. He is eighteen years old, so perhaps Cat Mask accidentally mated with another human and produced the Archseer, which created permanent downstream ripple effects on the timeline."

Primary: "This scenario is unlikely. I do not believe the Archseer is the nexus event that altered the timeline. We should return to the three-Hero theory. There must be a third Trueborn. This one has been attempting to hide from us. Cat Mask's ability to teleport may be a smokescreen to hide the existence of the third Trueborn. They are likely to be the one that caused the Nexus Event."

Secondary: "Agreed. But how do we deal with a rewinding Hero who can interact with us across multiple timelines and learn information we have no way of knowing he obtained? This presents a security and logistical nightmare."

Tertiary: "I have already come up with multiple possible counters to his ability. We need to develop a randomization system for our interactions with him, as well as a secret code that will allow us to determine whether or not he has accessed certain information ahead of time. By using careful and specific wording, we can ensure our verbal passwords will go undetected and Cat Mask will not see through our deception."

Primary: "This approach is flawed. Cat Mask seems extremely intelligent. He might see through our coded language."

Tertiary: "Agreed. That is why we must also attempt to create a method that can determine if the timeline has been altered, or perhaps come up with a temporal scanning device that can inform us of the number of changes to the timeline. It must be covert enough that Cat Mask will be unable to detect it."

Primary: "Is such a device possible to create?"

Tertiary: "Unknown. We may need to acquire the services of a different temporal manipulator. The only other known asset with such an ability is Archangel Camael, but if there are two Sentients that can alter the timelines or perceive the future, then there may be others."

Secondary: "Enough about Cat Mask. We must discuss how to escape this makeshift prison. I have looked through our abilities and decided none of them are acceptable. We must think outside the box if we intend to escape."

Ose's three minds operated at 100,000x realspeed. In less than one second, she came up with multiple possible contingency plans for Cat Mask, as well as a possible way to escape Area 51.

Just as Ose was about to act, a voice spoke up behind her.

"Hey, beautiful. Miss me?"

Ose instantly whirled around. Lightning crackled in her palms as she spotted Cat Mask standing with his hands in his pockets, smiling at her.

"You!" Ose shouted. "Come to sexually harass me again, you fiend?!"

"Well, that does sound like fun, but actually I came back because I forgot I left you here." Cat Mask said, smiling apologetically. "Oh right, did I tell you my name was Hideki? Because it's Hideki. You can call me 'sweet Hideki', or 'my precious Hideki', or 'my beloved Hideki.' Whatever rolls off the tongue!"

"I'd rather rip out my tongue than refer to you in such vomit-inducing terms!" Ose bit back.

"Not much of a romantic, huh?" Cat Mask asked. "That's fine. I like a challenge. Anyway, want me to let you out?"

"NO!" Ose shouted, more out of spite than anything else. There wasn't a shot in hell she was going to rely on his 'generosity'. "Get out of my face, and don't you dare come back!"

Hideki frowned, looking somewhat aggrieved. "Oh, darling Ose, you wound me. I'll leave you here, if that's what you want. How about a goodbye kiss though? You do love kissing me, don't you?"

"SEX PEST!!" Ose roared, before firing thirteen thunderbolts at his face.

Hideki vanished, leaving her to stand there and look for him. He didn't return.

Ose's eye twitched. She returned to what she was doing, sighing internally that Hideki probably already knew what she was going to attempt. If it failed, he'd return and mock her, saying something about how if she just fell into his arms, he'd whisk her away and teleport her out of Area 51...

But she had to try. She could not yet glean useful information off Hideki because her secret contingencies hadn't even been started. If she failed to escape, then she failed. She would have to fight her way out when the human military personnel arrived.

Ose's eyes turned deadly serious. She calmed down her breathing and focused her mind.

All three of her spiritual brains began working in unison as she pressed her palms on top of one another, then slowly lifted them apart.

A bead of highly focused electricity began to spiral in her grasp. This energized orb rapidly increased in heat and luminosity, brightening the dark room more and more every second. It expanded in size and heat, raising the ambient temperature of the room from a hundred degrees to several hundred. Ose started to sweat a little, making beads of liquid drip down her body. She cursed inside her mind, praying Hideki wouldn't return and get an eyeful of a sight he didn't deserve to enjoy.

The orb of plasma revolved faster and faster in her hand. It spun to life, creating a steady, deafening roar that increased in decibels every second.

Soon, it was the size of a baseball, and the orb's temperature had risen to over 100,000 degrees. Ose gritted her teeth, then slowly pushed her palms toward the double-doors. The spiraling orb of energy screeched as it struck the door and sent thousands of sparks flying. Even so, Ose gasped inside her mind when she saw the door starting to warp and deform where the orb was touching it.

Second after second, bit by bit, she maintained the pressure of her plasmic orb and pressed it against the door while fearfully praying the Archseer wouldn't suddenly arrive and strike her down during a moment of inattentiveness. Luckily, he did not, or perhaps could not. Even with their enchantments, Hideki and his son would probably die within seconds if they entered now.

The door buckled slightly. Molten alloys began to drip off its inner surface and splash against the floor, nearly hitting her foot and causing her serious wounds. Luckily, Ose dodged them all with her lithe and nimble movements.

Minutes passed. The heat in the room was so sweltering that any ordinary human would die within moments, while Ose was simultaneously sweating buckets only to have that sweat instantly dry up as soon as it escaped her skin's confines.

She was not Beelzebub. She was not effectively immune to all forms of heat, but compared to other demons, she was at least highly resistant to the effects of heat.

Ten minutes after she began, a hole the size of a fist was visible in the center of the door. Ose finally desummoned her plasmic orb and gasped for breath, each inhalation forcing her to swallow acrid smoke made up of unknown toxic alloy elements.

She didn't complain. As soon as she was able to peer through the hole, she turned her body into a beam of lightning and transmitted outside.

Ose was finally free!

She had completely failed her mission. She hadn't acquired the AI core she wanted, and she had been badly humiliated by Cat Mask.

Even so, she wasn't in low spirits. Ose's eyes flashed with insight.

I now know that aliens known as Volgrim exist, and that they are likely monitoring this planet. Hideki called their vessel an 'escape pod', which means this is not actually one of their proper ships. If I can come into contact with the Volgrim, I might be able to ascertain their intentions.

Ose smirked. Her expression was devious and ill-meaning.

She looked up at the ceiling, then launched her body straight upward like a railgun.

BOOOOM!!

Ose pounded through the upper ten levels one after another and arrived back in the fresh air, where the early morning sun had just become fully visible over the horizon. As Ose launched herself into the sky, she swept her surroundings with her demonic senses and chuckled at a distant approaching helicopter, then turned into a beam of light and transmitted away.

She had successfully escaped before the human military could apprehend her.

Part 674: Superior Sasha

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

While Ose's assault on Area 51 and the demons' initial movements toward Heaven had begun, one of Jason's Dronesmiths had continued to converse with Daisy and her three friends, Nadia, Sasha, and Marco. Indeed, despite spending several hours talking to Nadia to better get to know her abilities, not even a minute had passed in realspace. Ose's attack was still in its initial phase!

"Nadia, I've gotten a good grasp on your power." Jason said. "I'm going to give you a bunch of learning material, and I want you to spend the next several weeks reading all of it. With that Regeneration Band keeping your body intact, you'll be able to use your power as much as you want."

Nadia smiled. "Thank you, Mister Hiro."

Jason smiled back. Then he looked at Marco and Sasha.

"Which one of you wants to go next?" Jason asked.

Marco lowered his eyes. Sasha beamed. She was the most assertive of the group.

"Me!"

"Alright, alright." Jason said. He looked at Marco for a moment before returning his attention to Sasha. "You said before your power...?"

"I haven't really used it much. It didn't seem very useful..." Sasha said hesitantly. "But I was able to take the rust off a knife and move it to a different knife."

Jason blinked. "Alright. We'll start by trying that, then."

He waved his hand, and a large kitchen counter appeared in front of Sasha. Her eyes sparkled with interest at the ease with which he'd just summoned it, but she stayed quiet until he finished.

Jason conjured two knives. Both of them had dull blades, so they couldn't easily hurt someone if Sasha lost her grip and dropped them, or whatever. Better to be safe than sorry. One of the knives appeared to be in relatively pristine condition, while the other was badly rusted and looked to be in terrible shape.

"Go ahead." Jason said. "Transfer the rust from the ugly knife to the pristine one."

Sasha nodded. She paused for a moment, then clapped her hands together. After that, she took hold of the rusty knife's handle, then she grabbed the pristine one.

Something incredible happened that the others couldn't perceive. Rust quickly started disappearing off the first knife, only to grow on the second one as if it were being infected. By the end, the originally gross-looking knife looked like it had been scrubbed in an anti-rust solution. It wasn't in amazing condition, but it looked serviceable at the least. Sadly, the other knife was ruined.

After finishing, Sasha carefully set the knives down and took a step back. She looked respectfully at Jason.

"Any ideas, sir?" She asked, folding her hands over her waist.

"Hmm." Jason grunted.

Unbeknownst to Daisy and her friends, Jason was Wordsmithing like crazy in the background. He inspected the knives and compared their material composition, finding all sorts of strange phenomena.

"If I'm not mistaken..." Jason's Dronesmith said slowly. "You've somehow... transferred... a part of the rusty knife to the clean one. I don't know how to explain it."

"I have an idea." Nadia said, her eyes glowing blue as she looked from Sasha to the knives and back. "I think if you look at the magical pathways in Sasha's body while she repeats the action, things will be a lot clearer."

Jason nodded. "Alright. Sasha, try moving the rust back to the original knife."

She nodded obediently, then clapped her hands together. The moment she did, a flicker of light passed through the Dronesmith's eyes. Jason observed her body's internal mana pathways. He didn't say anything, but his heart jumped!

Sasha re-transferred the rust back to the original ugly knife, then set both knives back on the table. She looked at Jason, waiting for his assessment.

"Why do you clap your hands together?" Jason suddenly asked.

Sasha cocked her head. "I don't know? I just do it because it feels natural."

"In order to activate your powers, do you always have to clap your hands?" Jason asked, his tone filled with deep intent.

"Probably..." Sasha said. Without being asked, she picked up both of the knives and tried to reverse the process yet again.

Nothing happened.

"That's what I thought." Jason said. "You need to 'activate' your power to use it. When you clapped your palms together, there was a sudden burst of mana inside your body. It didn't centralize on your palms until you reached for the knives. I suspect it would also work through your feet if you 'willed' it to be so."

In Jason's eyes, this process was similar to how he Wordsmithed. If he didn't speak, he couldn't activate his power. The same was true if Sasha didn't clap her hands!

"Okay..." Sasha said quietly. "So other than that, what's going on? What are my powers doing? Just transferring rust around items?"

"It can't be something that mundane." Jason said. He paused then looked at Nadia. "Any thoughts?"

Nadia was extremely perceptive. Jason had ideas about what was going on, but the more time he spent with Nadia, the more her powers impressed him.

"I don't know what Sasha's power is, but I think we could try some experiments." Nadia said. "Sasha, why don't you try transferring something else from one knife to the other?"

"Something else?" Sasha asked, confused.

"Yes. For example, why don't you try making one of the knives 'thicker'?"

"Uhh..."

Sasha looked at Nadia with a weird expression. Then she shrugged, clapped her hands, and grabbed the knives again.

This time, nothing seemed to happen visually. For several seconds, Sasha simply stared at the two knives with a dumb expression.

Then, out of nowhere, one of the knives suddenly collapsed! It broke apart in her hands and fell into countless tiny shards of metal, falling through her fingers and cutting her palms open where her grip accidentally pressed the sharp metal bits against her skin.

"Ow!!" Sasha yelped, opening her hand and letting the shards fall atop the counter.

Without verbalizing his intent, Jason healed her hands, instantly stopping the bleeding. His Drone took a few steps closer and held out its hand.

"Let me look at that knife." Jason said.

Sasha nodded. She handed the knife over, and Jason's drone took it and stared at it for a moment.

"The knife's internal structure has been altered. It is currently 47.3% denser than before Sasha's latest experiment." He observed.

Nadia's eyes glowed. "Denser? Is it possible she transferred the other knife's density over to the one in your hand?"

"That seems a likely explanation..." Jason said. "If she did, then she likely created countless weak points all across the first knife, which caused a structural collapse. That's why it suddenly fell apart in her hand."

Marco, who had been quiet up to this point, decided to speak. "What if Sasha's not 'transferring' attributes from one object to another?"

"If not, then what do you think she's doing?" Daisy asked.

"I don't know. I just think this power of hers is a little... weird." Marco said, uncertain of the full idea percolating in the back of his brain.

Nadia, however, seemed to get a hint from his implication. "Sasha, clap your hands and... try... try doing something to that knife. Now that it's denser than before, can you alter its properties?"

"I don't know..." Sasha said uncertainly. "I'll try..."

She clapped her hands, then took hold of the knife. Uncertain of what to do with her other hand, Sasha started to reach out and touch the table, but before she could, the knife turned to a strange wax-like substance in her hand. It heatlessly melted, then collapsed into mush in her grasp.

Sasha looked alarmed, but Nadia's eyes sparkled with blue light.

"You altered the knife's properties!" Nadia proclaimed. "What were you thinking when you melted it?"

"I wasn't really thinking anything." Sasha said, shaking the melted mess off her hands and onto the table. "I just wanted it to change."

"Alright. Let's try something else then." Nadia said, before turning to Jason. "Create several iron pipes, then put them on the table."

Jason raised an eyebrow. He originally planned to do all the experimenting, but he also found it interesting letting Nadia take charge. Clearly, she was seeing something he and the others weren't. With a wave of his hand, Jason conjured a dozen foot-long pipes on the table.

"Alright, Sasha." Nadia said. "This time, I want you to clap your hands, take hold of a pipe, and then imagine changing its color."

"Its color?" Sasha repeated, giving Nadia a strange look.

"Yes. Imagine that the pipe is colored red in your mind's eye, then make it so." Nadia said.

"Alright..." Sasha said, her tone uncertain.

She did as Nadia commanded. She clapped her hands, picked up a pipe, and visualized in her mind's eye the pipe turning firetruck red.

Instead, the pipe only turned a little bit rusty before it start sagging at the far end, as if it were made of licorice and gravity were pulling it downward.

Nadia gasped. "There! Where your hand is touching. Look!"

Sasha set the pipe down. Right where her hand had gripped the pipe, it was colored bright-red. The rest of the pipe seemed the same as before, albeit 'droopier'.

"You've altered the physical properties of the pipe. I was correct in my hypothesis." Nadia said. "Try again with a different pipe. This time, just touch the pipe with a finger on each end. Try to imagine turning it firetruck red, like the color on the first pipe."

Sasha nodded. Seeing that the first pipe's conversion had partially succeeded, she did as Nadia instructed. This time, when she touched the second pipe with one finger on each end, everyone in the room gasped.

She succeeded! The pipe rapidly changed color, morphing from silvery-gray to a bright red coloration.

Sasha's jaw dropped. "I... I... what does this mean? What is my power doing?"

"You're a pretty smart person." Nadia said. "Don't you remember taking chemistry in high school? You're altering the properties of the matter you touch when you use your

power."

Sasha blinked. "Altering... what does that even mean?"

"You weren't confident before. You didn't believe in yourself, or believe that your power had any use." Nadia said, more certain of her hypothesis than ever. She walked around the table and smiled as she rested a palm on Sasha's back. "But the more confident you become, the stronger your power is. More specifically, your power has a lot to do with your Imagination, your Mind's Eye, and the Belief you hold in yourself. I want you to try something different now. Try turning this third steel pipe into a knife, like the one from earlier."

"You want me to change it from a pipe into a knife?" Sasha repeated, somewhat bewildered. "I understand changing the colors, but-"

"Just do it." Nadia said. "Don't question. Don't disbelieve. Just think about the process, and do it. I believe in you."

The solemness in Nadia's voice eventually pushed down Sasha's disbelief. With a serious look on her face, Sasha nodded. She clapped her hands together, imagined the pipe turning into a knife... then she touched it.

Every person in the room widened their eyes. The pipe rapidly shifted shape. It changed in the blink of an eye, turning from an ordinary steel pipe into an admittedly ugly and impractical facsimile of the knives Sasha had been manipulating a few minutes earlier.

It wasn't perfect. The 'knife' she had created with her power was rudimentary, and only somewhat shaped correctly. From a distance, a man with terrible vision might mistake it for a knife, but its weird and wobbly hilt and uneven 'blade' that wasn't sharp enough to cut tofu marked it as an amateur's mistake.

But Sasha wasn't discouraged. Her eyes shone with excitement. She squeezed her hands into fists and shook, doing a little dance of excitement.

"Oh my gosh! I... I don't know what I just did! What's going on? What is my power, Nadia?!"

Nadia gave Sasha a big hug, then pulled away.

"Matter and Energy are interlinked. You are able to alter the chemical composition of objects based on images formed in your mind. Right now, your knowledge of knives is so

rudimentary and basic that you can't properly reshape the pipe as you'd like, but I believe, given time, this will change."

"Your power," Nadia continued, "allows you to reshape matter when you touch it. However, it seems you cannot add or subtract matter, only alter what already exists. By breaking down objects into a more malleable state, you can then reshape the matter into something better befitting your intention."

Jason's eyes flashed. "What you described sounds an awful lot like Alchemy. Turning lead into gold."

"That's a good way of putting it." Nadia said, before glancing at one of the pipes. "Sasha, try turning this pipe into gold."

Sasha's mouth formed an 'o' as she ooh'd and ahh'd at that particular possibility. Without wasting time, she clapped her hands and eagerly touched the iron pipe.

A few moments later... a small area where she touched had turned yellow in color, but it wasn't exactly gold. Sasha's excitement deflated a little.

"Don't be disappointed. You have a shallow understanding of material physics." Nadia said. "If we can train you to better comprehend the atomic structure of the universe, you'll be able to use your power more adeptly."

Jason looked at Daisy. She looked at him.

"What?" Daisy asked.

Jason lightly chewed on his lower lip. "I was originally thinking of outfitting Nadia with a MindCore. Now it seems Sasha is an equally valuable candidate. I'm debating which one to upgrade first."

"And you're looking at me, because...?" Daisy asked.

"Because I should get you one, too." Jason said. "Honestly, all of you should have one. Even Marco, though I'll need to figure out what his power is first."

Marco was definitely next on Jason's list, but right now he had to think about how best to learn about, test, and study Sasha's power.

"Let's try more options." Jason said. He summoned many different objects, ranging from a suit of armor to a television to a car engine. "We'll start by having you reshape all of these objects into new forms to learn where your limits lie."

Sasha looked a little overwhelmed, but she didn't complain. It wasn't every day someone learned they had been possessing a reality-defying power their entire life, yet had completely wasted its potential.

* * *

Several hours later, Sasha grabbed another iron pipe. Her power entered the pipe, and it rapidly changed shape, flowing back onto her hand and turning into a somewhat shabby-looking but perfectly functional iron gauntlet. She flexed her fingers and smiled. She'd managed to make the joints adjustable, rather than rigid, like the last time.

"Your power is Alchemy." Nadia stated. "You can alter matter from one form to another. Solid, liquid, gaseous. You can also change material into other materials, but only within reason. Turning one kilogram of iron into one kilogram of plutonium is impossible. They have completely different atomic structures. But if two types of material are relatively similar, you can alter them. You can even change the shape of Jason's super-metal, but it's extremely difficult due to its magically-empowered state."

"Archseerium." Jason said, not wanting to refer to it by the name of Wordsmithium in case it leaked his true abilities. "It's tougher than diamond. Or pretty much any material you can find on Earth."

"It's also much harder for Sasha to alter." Nadia said. "Changing its shape is one thing, but changing it to a new type of material is basically impossible."

Sasha turned to Jason. "Can you summon some fabric for me? Enough to make some clothing."

Jason shrugged. "Sure."

He waved his hand, and a pile of red and yellow fabric fell on the table in front of Sasha. She stayed silent for several long seconds, then she clapped her hands and picked up the fabric. It quickly changed into a beautiful red dress, one that had strange sparkling holographic colors that glittered all throughout it. When she held it up to the light, it shone with a rainbow light that dazzled the eyes.

"I'm pretty good with fashion stuff." Sasha said, after a moment of embarrassment. "Making weapons and armor aren't really my talents, but I'm great at visualizing clothing. I'll try to get better at other stuff, but for now, being able to summon any clothing I want feels fabulous!"

Jason smiled. "If you want, I can summon that dress onto you. Or I can make a dressing room for you to get changed."

"The latter." Sasha said, before quickly adding, "I'd just prefer to change my own clothes."

"Sure, sure. One second." Jason replied.

At the back corner of the room, Jason conjured a sealed area with a door leading in and out. Sasha walked over and entered, then stepped back out after a minute or two. The red dress looked gorgeous on her, and she did a little spin to show it off.

"Alchemy." Jason said, quietly chuckling to himself. "I suspect this power will prove incredibly potent, given time. Sasha, Nadia, while I have you here, why don't I tell you about my MindCores? I have a feeling they're going to prove extremely useful for the both of you."

Jason launched into an explanation of the MindCores he had invented. Not only did Nadia and Sasha listen with great interest, but so did Marco and Daisy.

"So those are the options." Jason concluded after a while. "The GenesisFrame, which I use, is focused on research, inventions, and creating things. The RealitySim allows you to simulate entire worlds or alternate realities inside your mind. The QuantumReflex will directly increase your combat capabilities. The HellProphet... allows you to predict the movements of the future, and other beings. And finally, the OmniRecord gives you a general purpose cerebral improvement with no downsides. Accelerated thinking, infinite memory storage, and so on."

The teenagers all quietly thought to themselves about which MindCore would best augment their abilities. Only Marco, who still didn't know the extent of his power, was unable to form any sort of conclusive opinion.

"The RealitySim works best for me." Nadia said. "The GenesisFrame is appealing too, but I think based on your descriptions, the RealitySim fits my skillset perfectly."

Jason nodded. "That was my thought as well."

"I think if Nadia is taking the RealitySim, I should choose something else." Sasha said. "I need a lot of conceptual power, so I believe the GenesisFrame is best suited for me."

"I want a QuantumReflex." Daisy said without hesitation. "You haven't given this particular MindCore to anyone else yet, have you, dad?"

Jason looked at his daughter in surprise. "I haven't, but are you sure you want a MindCore that's so deeply focused on short-term benefits? The other Cores all have limitless capabilities for growth. By comparison, the QuantumReflex..."

"I know what you're thinking." Daisy said, "but my powers are not focused on Imagination. I've had lots of time to master my core abilities. In the future, if I hope to battle Demon Emperors, then I will need enhanced senses and reaction times. Nothing is more important to me than becoming a soldier for humanity."

Jason looked at his daughter. He smiled and nodded.

"If that's what you want, then the QuantumReflex will soon be yours."

He turned to Marco after a moment. "And you?"

Marco shook his head. "The decision is too important. I don't even know what my power is yet."

"Then I guess we'd better remedy that first." Jason said.

The Wordsmith looked around the room, then shook his head.

"Here's no good. Let's go outside Argent's walls, where there's more open space. Then you'll have more room to... *snap* things out of reality."

Part 675: Marco Snaps

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Jason took the teenagers out into the open area beyond Argent's walls. This place was known as The Proving Grounds, and in the future Jason planned for it to contain increasingly more dangerous and powerful beasts and exobeasts. He would pluck strong ones from worlds across the Milky Way, place them inside the Proving Grounds, and force them to evolve through unending survival and combat. The wilderness and jungle would claim countless lives, but the remaining champions would become fearsome without parallel.

Right now though, it was primitive and harmless. Mostly. There were probably some venomous insects and little blood-sucking parasites buzzing around, but a little over a year simply wasn't enough time for Axis Mundi and its unending source of Genesis Ichor to truly transform the life inside Aevum. There were birds, cat, dogs, and other small life forms that had undoubtedly began to mutate, but they would still need a decade or two to grow as formidable as the apex predators on Earth.

"These are the Ironwoods." Jason said, gesturing to the dense foliage around his group. "They shouldn't be too dangerous now, but in time, they will be. Whatever you do, do not eat or drink anything you find in this forest. Especially, and I cannot emphasize this enough… *especially* do not drink any standing or running water. It will screw up your body in ways you cannot imagine."

Marco rubbed his hands together nervously. "Then w-why have you brought us here if the place is so scary?"

"Your power is strange, and potentially dangerous." Jason explained. "I thought a wider open area to test your ability would be best."

He gestured toward a clearing in the forest. It wasn't large, perhaps only the size of a small shack, but it was big enough for the group of five to stand at the eastern edge and throw a softball into the western edge with relative ease.

"Well, I know that when you snap your fingers, things disappear, then reappear. So why don't you go ahead and do that for me?" Jason asked.

Marco nodded. He looked at the trees less than a hundred feet away, held up his hand, and snapped his fingers.

Suddenly, as if a giant invisible beach ball had taken a bite out of reality, a huge sphere opened up in the forest cover. Part of the ground vanished, revealing a concave depression. The trees above that spot vanished, except for their tree-tops, which had been completely severed from the missing trunks. Those canopies started to fall, only for the missing trees and ground to abruptly reappear, phasing into the falling canopies and causing a weird vibration as two confusing realities merged together.

After a few moments, the strange vibrations ceased. Two trees fell over and collapsed inside the clearing, while the others looked as if their canopies had been sliced off, then placed back on top of the severed trunks haphazardly.

"Amazing..." Nadia whispered, her eyes glowing blue.

Jason took a step forward, then paused to look at Marco. "Don't do anything else. Let me examine the scene."

Marco nodded. He didn't say a word.

The Wordsmith flickered forward. He arrived inside the mass of disheveled trees, then took a few minutes to inspect them, uttering Words of Power inside the center of his sanctum that traveled through the conduit of energy attached to his Dronesmith. He inspected the scene for a while, then walked back over.

"I believe you are temporarily erasing a bubble of space, then bringing it back one second later." Jason said. "But the curious thing is, there's signs of damage to the trees caused by aging. These trees are all quite young, so it's really obvious when days or even weeks of growth are separating their tops from their trunks and roots."

"What does that mean?" Marco asked.

"I'm not sure. Let's find out." Jason said with a smile.

He walked back over to the fallen trees, then pointed at Marco.

"Snap your fingers while aiming at me."

Marco nearly jumped out of his skin. "What! No way!! Sir, you don't even know what my power does! You could die!"

"Unlikely." Jason retorted. "I haven't told you guys this, but you're not looking at my real body. This is a drone I made with my powers."

He detached his arm at the shoulder, revealing its internal metallic components. "See?"

Daisy's eyes narrowed. She finally understood why she hadn't been able to read her father's thoughts, and she felt... slightly betrayed. Annoyed, at the very least. *Why didn't he tell me?!*

"Oh... so it's a drone..." Marco said softly. "Well... alright. But are you sure, Mister Hiro, sir?"

"I'm sure." Jason said, giving him a thumbs up. "Snap me."

Marco gritted his teeth. After taking a moment to steady his nerves, he snapped his fingers, and Jason's drone disappeared, along with a massive chunk of ground surrounding him.

One second later, Jason reappeared. But he wasn't standing. He was laying face-down in the grass, unmoving.

"Oh... oh my god!!" Marco screamed, shocked out of his mind. He started to shake with fear. "Mister Hiro? Mister Hiro??!!"

After a moment, Jason's drone twitched. It lifted itself up with its hands, then returned to a standing position.

"Alright. That was strange." Jason said.

"Are you okay?" Marco asked, running over with shaky hands. "I'm so sorry! I didn't mean-"

"Calm down, it's fine." Jason said, before cocking his head. "Oh? The battery on my drone has dropped to 99%. That's unusual. When in Aevum, the drone should be at 100% constantly. It has the power to absorb energy from the leylines under the soil."

Daisy gave her father a bizarre look. "Then what happened?"

Jason didn't answer for a few seconds. He frowned, then tapped his chin thoughtfully.

"It takes a good week or two for my drone to lose 1% of its power while passively standing still. The energy drain would be a lot higher if it engaged in active movement,

combat, or utilized its internal abilities. For it to lose 1% of its battery while doing nothing implies... time passed inside the 'spatial bubble'."

Nadia looked at Jason meaningfully. "Did you lose your connection to the drone?"

"I did. It felt as if the energy line was severed, which is extremely odd, given it can persist across dimensions like Aevum, the Labyrinth, Heaven, and other such places."

"Does your drone have an internal chronometer?" Nadia asked.

Jason looked at her. Then he checked the drone's databanks.

"What the... its internal date is off by two weeks. It experienced two weeks of time despite only being gone for a single second from our point of view."

Jason's eyes flashed.

"It's... it's like the Stillness! Marco is somehow sucking things into a sealed dimension with a hyper-accelerated temporal flow. That explains a lot."

"Marco," Nadia said, "didn't you tell us that when you were a kid, you used your power on a dog attacking you? And when the dog reappeared, it looked like it had been dead for days? It must have been trapped inside the temporal field for two weeks without food and water. That's why it perished."

Marco's face turned pale. "So I really did kill that dog?! God! Oh my god, how awful!!"

"It was an accident. No reason to blame yourself." Jason said coolly. "More importantly, I think you're missing the bigger picture. This ability of yours is something special. Let's run some more tests."

Jason manufactured a few different items. He made a clock with the date and time on its front, a fast-growing algae inside a solution of water, and even a colony of termites with ample food placed on top of their glass enclosure.

After putting them in a small area atop a stone platform, Jason gave Marco the go-ahead. Marco snapped his fingers, and a large sphere instantly swallowed the items along with the ground they were standing on. One second later, they reappeared.

Jason walked over. He noticed that the stone platform may have reappeared inside the same spot, but it was slightly off position and hadn't seamlessly merged with the stone that was left behind. There were visible cracks and gaps in a circle around the voided platform.

But soon he turned his attention to other matters.

"The clock shows that exactly one week, six days, twenty-three hours, fifty-nine minutes, and fifty-nine seconds passed from the moment you voided the area to the moment it reappeared. One second shy of two weeks, on the dot."

"So... that means... I'm trapping things inside a sealed dimension for two weeks?" Marco asked.

"Sure looks that way." Jason said.

He fell silent. Several seconds passed.

Jason examined the algae. It had grown in density a little, enough to suggest a week or two had passed. The termites had eaten most of the food and their colony had increased in population somewhat.

Eventually, Jason turned to the side. His father, Hideki, abruptly appeared, teleported there by the Wordsmith.

"Dad. Help me out for a minute." Jason said.

Hideki's body blurred. He shrugged. "It's safe."

Jason opened his mouth to speak, but then shut it. Hideki had already answered the question he wanted to ask.

Seeing that his son was satisfied, Hideki turned and smiled at Daisy. "Hey, sweetie. How's my cute little granddaughter doing?"

"I'm doing fine... grandpa." Daisy said, not certain she was entirely comfortable using the word with him. Maybe she would get used to it in due time.

Hideki waved goodbye, then he vanished from the spot.

"That was your grandfather?" Sasha asked. "What even just happened?"

"He's a Trueborn like my dad and I." Daisy half-heartedly explained. "I'm guessing he used his power to help dad...?"

"Yeah." Jason said. He turned to Marco. "I'm going to bring my true body here. I want you to void the 'real' me."

Before Marco could utter a word of protest, a second Jason suddenly appeared. His Drone took a few steps back, while Jason walked over to the stone platform and stood in place.

"W-wait! Hold on! Isn't that dangerous?" Marco asked, looking at the other teenagers for confirmation.

They shrugged. Daisy touched his shoulder. "My grandpa said it was safe. So you can do it."

"Oh. Well, alright then..." Marco said quietly.

He gritted his teeth, then held up his hands. With an audible crack, he snapped his fingers. Jason disappeared.

* * *

Suddenly, Jason found that he was no longer inside Aevum. He had arrived inside a pitch-black area with zero visibility. He didn't become flustered. He could still breathe, which meant that there was oxygen around himself.

Seconds passed. He didn't return to Aevum.

I've lost contact with all my drones. Jason thought. *The temperature here seems no different from the Proving Grounds. Maybe Marco's power copies the environment the person is teleported from?*

He uttered a Word of Power. "**Light.**"

The surroundings brightened noticeably as Jason's body became bioluminescent. He lit up the area around himself, finding that he was still standing atop the stone platform, but now there was absolutely nothing past its edges. He appeared to be floating inside nothingness. His Wordsmithing also felt remarkably sluggish. There was a ten-meter-in-diameter sphere enveloping his body and the area around it, protecting it from a strange sort of 'nothingness' outside.

"**Return.**" Jason said.

Nothing happened. A chill went down his back.

"**Return! Teleport! Break! Shatter!**"

Jason tried multiple Words of Power, but he found that the sphere was inescapable. He momentarily started to panic, but that feeling quickly died down. His father had seen the future and told Jason it was safe to proceed, so that meant he wouldn't die here.

Jason started trying lots of things. He attempted to accelerate the time-flow of Marco's void dimension, but that had no effect. He tried creating an electric generator with his

magic, and that did succeed, which allowed him to set up some electric-powered lights. He tried sending a transmission out to Aevum, but he received no reply. No matter what light he shined toward the edges of the spherical dimension, he could see nothing but pitch-blackness outside.

"I'm completely trapped here." Jason said to himself quietly. "I can't escape at all. Not even my Wordsmithing will set me free. That's both horrifying and amazing. Could this void dimension trap other entities? Could it trap High Psions and other Cosmics? Could it trap... *Satan?*"

Jason started thinking. He realized after a short while that there were huge advantages to being inside this realm.

"If my hypothesis is correct, I have about two weeks inside the Void to progress my projects, whereas my Stillness only gives me maybe eight solid hours before I develop a massive migraine. Marco doesn't seem to grow fatigued by snapping his fingers, either, so he could snap me here over and over, giving me effectively infinite time to develop my potential!"

Jason's eyes widened. Since he was stuck here, couldn't escape, and couldn't get a message out, he might as well make the best of the situation.

Days passed. Jason used this gift of free time to rapidly iterate on his MindCores. He took the knowledge he had acquired over the last several Aevum-months and rapidly updated the MindCores from v2 to v3. He had only ever installed the GenesisFrame v1 inside his own brain, but now he had made so many huge advancements that once he put the v3 MindCores inside the brains of his allies, they would outperform him mentally in all categories!

"Amazing. Shocking." Jason murmured to himself on the 10th day. "Time is such a precious commodity, and now I can get massive amounts of it whenever I need. Marco is a precious asset. I cannot afford to lose him. I'll have to assign a protective detail to shadow him at all times. If the demons learn how valuable he is to me, he'll face an unending stream of assassination attempts!"

Time passed. Jason started to grow the beginnings of a beard, but he was too engrossed in his research to even notice. On occasion, Jason would look up from his work, thinking he had seen something moving out in the inky blackness of the Nothingness. These minor hallucinations irritated him, but luckily, they were only minor

signs he was going slightly crazy from isolation. It obviously couldn't be good to spend so many days alone without social contact.

Eventually, after two weeks, the Snap Dimension rumbled around him, and the void collapsed, returning him to Aevum.

Daisy and her friends looked worriedly at the spot where Jason was now sitting, one second having passed in Aevum-time.

"Dad! Dad, are you okay?" Daisy asked, rushing over to his side.

Jason looked up and blinked. "Oh, I'm back? Wow. That took a long time, but it didn't feel too long to me."

From the teenager's perspectives, Jason had been standing when he disappeared, then he reappeared a few feet off to the side, sitting in a comfortable easy chair, with finished bowls and plates of food piled off to the side. It looked as if he had eaten many, many meals in that 'one second' he was gone.

Jason yawned, stood up, and cracked his back.

"Alright," He said after a moment of letting the blood pulse through his veins. "It definitely takes two weeks for time to pass inside the Snap Dimension. Marco, your power is going to be extremely useful to me moving forward, since I can get a lot of work done in a very short period of time."

Marco nodded dumbly. "Um... alright. I'm glad I was able to help, Mister Hiro. You're really okay?"

"Sort of." Jason said, tapping his finger against his chin. "I sincerely doubt this is the full extent of your power though. I wonder if it isn't possible to extend or contract the duration of time spent inside? Maybe you could extend the time to a month, a year, or something else? Or maybe you could shrink it to only an hour or two? Definitely worth playing with. I'm going to create an autonomous drone assistant to help you test how your power works. I can confirm that running out of oxygen wasn't a problem, but running out of food and water was. If it had been Daisy you snapped, she... probably wouldn't have survived."

Jason spent a few minutes explaining what he did while inside the dimension. Nadia and the others listened intently as he told them about his newly upgraded Mindcores.

"The Snap Dimension won't do much to a demon if Marco tried trapping them." Daisy pointed out. "They're immortal creatures who don't even need to eat, drink, or breathe to survive. It'll just end up being a two-week inconvenience for them, then they'll escape one second later and kill Marco."

"Maybe we can kill them with boredom?" Sasha suggested.

Jason chuckled. "Like I said, there's zero chance a Trueborn like Marco has uncovered the full extent of his abilities. I'm fairly certain there's more his power can do... he'll just need to explore its full capabilities in due time."

Marco nodded slowly. After getting a decent grasp on all his power could achieve, he started thinking about the MindCores Jason had suggested.

"I don't think the GenesisFrame is right for me, though it would be cool to upgrade my brain with it. Generally speaking, it would be a huge benefit in my ordinary life." Marco said seriously. "The RealitySim seems like I could use it to model lots of different scenarios for my powers. The QuantumReflex probably won't suit me. The OmniRecord is also likewise good for general cerebral improvements..."

He looked thoughtful.

"Honestly, Mister Hiro... I think the HellProphet would be interesting. Predicting the future, predicting the consequences of my actions. Modeling what might happen if I locked one person or another inside my Snap Dimension. I think I'd like to use that one, if possible."

Jason looked surprised. "I didn't expect anyone to pick the HellProphet. But if each of you pick a different MindCore, we'll have a lot more data to work with. Unfortunately, I advanced all the MindCore designs except the HellProphet. I'll need to take some more time to..."

Jason paused, then laughed.

"Ah, never mind! I can just have you snap me again, Marco! I'll upgrade it later, right before I upgrade your brain. For right now, Nadia, Sasha, and Daisy are the higher priority upgrades. Their powers are more immediately useful."

Marco nodded and lowered his eyes. "It's fine, sir. My power isn't really all that useful compared to theirs. I'm sorry it's not very good."

Daisy frowned. She walked over and hugged Marco's shoulders with one arm. "Hey, don't talk down about yourself like that! You have a magical power! 99.99% of other humans don't! That means, even if it's 'not that useful', it's still something others can't do. It's a unique talent! And based on what my dad said, at the very least, it'll give humanity a massive boost in R&D time. I'm sure he and Nadia will be able to go inside and get TONS of work done over the next several months!"

Jason walked over and lightly clapped Marco on the back. "Daisy's right! Don't put yourself down. In fact, I want you to keep experimenting with your power. Use it lots, learn its limits, and find new and exciting ways to exploit what it can do. I'll assign Nadia to helping you master it and learning its strengths and weaknesses, before giving me a full breakdown. How's that sound?"

Marco smiled weakly. "Sure. I'll do that then, sir."

One thing was for certain. Marco was not a self-assured person. He had a noticeable inferiority complex... it reminded Jason of his own younger self. Always looking to other people for validation, constantly second-guessing himself, never believing he was good enough...

Jason thought about Amelia, about Phoebe, Kar, and lots of other people. Because of their words of encouragement, he managed to push past his own self-doubts and become a self-actualized Wordsmith. That was what Marco needed; the guiding words of his closest friends.

"Hey, we've been at this all day." Jason said. "Let's stop here for now. I'll make everyone some delicious food. How's that sound?"

"I want to help!" Nadia said. "I love cooking!"

"I do too!" Sasha said. "And Marco's dad is a professional chef. I bet he's better than all of us combined!"

Marco chuckled and touched his nose self-consciously. "Haha. Well, I have picked up a few things from my dad, it's true."

"Great. Then it's decided." Jason said with a smile. "Let's eat some food, get some rest, and pick up where we left off tomorrow."

With a wave of his hand, Jason teleported himself and the kids out of the clearing. They returned to Inner Argent, leaving behind only the cracked stone platform and the

pile of food bowls behind as evidence of their having been there.

For several long minutes, the forest remained still.

Then, the air slightly vibrated. For the briefest of instants, a faceless, shadowy figure hazily materialized inside the confines of the area where Marco's Snap Dimension had existed. The figure swayed from side to side in silence for a few moments... then it wavered out of existence and faded away, as if it had never been there...

The forest became still once more.

Part 676: A Dialogue With Dolgris

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Somewhere in the Southwest Milky Way Quadrant.

Founder Unarin sat inside the co-pilot's chair of his personal shuttle, the Founder's Spear. In the pilot's chair, Muuxunuu silently piloted the vessel, saying nothing to the First Founder. In the rear cabin, a single Dolgrimite, Cinculu, lounged while sipping a nutrient brew made of raw blood and several other detestable ingredients. He seemed to be quite enjoying the flavor.

The Founder's Spear cut through the void at a speed similar to what most Volgrim war vessels could achieve. Rather than burn precious Trifrancium more than needed, Unarin opted to travel at Warp 7.5 and arrive at Grimvolas in a slower but more reasonable time. He wasn't in a rush.

It had been a little over two Terran-weeks since Mephisto's assault on Volgarius, the Dolgrimite's rise, and all the other insanity that happened in a disturbingly short period of time. Two weeks was not a long time, but it wasn't short, either. Unarin had read scattered reports regarding the humans on Sharmur and how they had already constructed the skeleton of a new human capital city. Rumors were flying that the Dolgrimites had suppressed or eliminated the Kolvaxian infection on dozens of worlds, and the situation across the Milky Way was on its way to a slow and tedious stabilization.

But Unarin did not grow complacent.

Peace was not the natural state of the universe. Akasha did not like peace. He loved to see war, death, and calamity spread through civilized space. He had created the Akashic Rules explicitly to foment wars and power struggles, all for the sake of amusing himself.

Whenever the situation seemed to be improving, that was when things would turn around and become worse than before...

The Founder's Spear beeped an alert. The Grimvolas system was less than ten standard time units away. Unarin blinked his eyes, then he stood up, exited the cockpit, and walked back to the rear cabin. It was this very area where he had once hosted Humanity's Hero, the Wordsmith. Now, it held the figure of his fellow Founder, Cinculu.

"Unarin." Cinculu said. "News?"

"We're soon to arrive in the Grimvolas system." Unarin said. "Where would you like for us to land?"

Cinculu glowered at the First Founder. He was still pissed at the brazen request Unarin had made to speak to the Dolgrimites' god, but the matter was out of his claws. Matriarch Gorzana had personally spoken to Dolgris and confirmed the meeting. Cinculu could do nothing more than escort Unarin there and pray the First Founder did not enrage Lord Dolgris.

Minutes later, the Founder's Spear arrived in the Grimvolas System. It rapidly made its way to the ancient Volgrim's original homeworld, then cut through the upper atmosphere, traveling toward a sacred temple located on the western edge of a great mountain plateau.

Atop that plateau, there were hundreds of Dolgrimites dressed in warrior armor. Some were colored gold, others red, others blue and green and black. Each one was part of a unique division suited to carrying out certain battle formations and orders more effectively than their peers. All were extremely dangerous.

Cinculu couldn't help but walk over and stand beside Unarin, sneering contemptuously at his peer. "You see? This is the strength of the Dolgrimites. What you are seeing is but a tiny fraction of our whole army. The elites among the elites. If we were to battle your Psions, we would crush them with ease. The Plague will soon be nothing more than an unpleasant memory from our past."

Unarin glanced at him. "Boastful claims require great evidence to confirm. Since the Psions have all been brought to ruin, it's a shame you'll never be able to validate your words."

Cinculu's eyes twitched. He had once again tried to go up against the First Founder in a battle of words, yet had come up short. He quickly took a step away and chuffed in annoyance.

"You had best mind your manners when speaking to the great Dolgris!" Cinculu spat. "Your glib tongue might just land you in a situation not even Dosena can help you escape."

"Oh, good." Unarin said dryly. "I was worried this would end up being a dreadfully boring meeting. It seems I'll be able to enjoy myself after all."

Cinculu, seeing he hadn't gotten the reaction he wanted, instead stalked away and sat back down, sulking in annoyance. He could never defeat the First Founder in a battle of words. It was impossible.

If only he could release the beast within himself and beat the shit out of Unarin, he could introduce Unarin's smug face to the ground and teach him to respect those who were more powerful. Alas, Cinculu found that he had been shackled by the rules of a game he didn't even know he was playing. His mother, the Matriarch, was the true ruler of Grimvolas. He could not defy her commands.

The Founder's Spear set down in the center of a landing platform. There were very few spacecraft in orbit and on the surface of Grimvolas. All of them were controlled by Technopaths who had made trade agreements with the Dolgrimites, and thus were nominally owned by the Dolgrimite Matriarch. None of those ships were visible even from a kilometer above sea level.

The landing platform extended outward. Unarin casually strode down it, looking more bored than ever. He glanced around at the 'intimidating' display of power by the Dolgrimite Elites and found it all rather banal and distasteful.

"Founder Unarin." Matriarch Gorzana said, standing at the end of the procession. She wore golden armor that clung tightly to her muscled body; something Unarin believed she had only worn to try and sow a hint of fear in the back of his mind. Naturally, it didn't work. Unarin feared nothing.

"Hello, Matriarch." Unarin said. "Not to be a bother, but I hope you don't plan to put me to sleep with too many of these idle pleasantries. Let's be on our way to meet your God, if you please."

Gorzana's eye twitched. Like mother, like son, she too came up short when it came to political talk with someone of Unarin's caliber.

Still, she didn't let her annoyance show. She smiled widely. "Yes, of course. Lord Dolgris has waited long enough for your arrival. I did not expect you to take a scenic route, so I must say I am rather displeased by the time needed for your trip."

"Apologies." Unarin said blandly, as he walked over and stopped in front of her, Cinculu trailing behind him. "I had a few important matters to deal with on Volgarius. I'm pleased you were able to convince your great God to speak to a humble mortal like myself. Hopefully, he will not be enraged by my delays."

"Dolgris is lofty. Dolgris is slow to anger." Gorzana said with upraised eyes. "He is long-lived, and far older than even yourself. A few extra cycles are of little concern to one as ancient as he. Come. I shall take you to meet him."

Unarin nodded. He fell into stride beside Gorzana, while Cinculu shuffled along behind both. He seemed a rather sorry figure, unworthy of being on the same level as the two of them, despite supposedly being a Founder himself. Seeds of resentment at this fact had long bubbled within Cinculu's gut, but he dared not say anything so long as the Matriarch controlled Grimvolas's armies.

The trio walked deep into the underground depths. Unlike the other Volgrim, the Dolgrimites burrowed inside mountains and underneath the landmasses of Grimvolas. Their underground cities were both sprawling and impressive, with room for billions of Dolgrimites all across the world. They chose not to live on the surface, instead allowing the planet's natural creatures to prosper. At night, the Dolgrimites would come out to hunt, and countless great slaughters would occur all at once as their prey screamed and squawked in the final moments of their lives.

They passed by enormous guest chambers, halls of feasting, sacrificial pyres, and countless other religious monuments depicting various images of the 'face' of their God. Unfortunately, each of these images was different from the others, showing none of the artists and sculptors had ever personally come into contact with Dolgris. The variations were far too extreme, and it was obvious to Unarin that there must be some contention as to what sort of entity Dolgris even *was*.

He looked at the side of Gorzana's face. Then he looked away.

"Is something on your mind?" Gorzana asked, sensing his gaze.

"I am growing more and more curious about Dolgris." Unarin said, speaking mainly to fill the silence. "What sort of tenets does he command that you live by?"

Gorzana snorted. "Hmph. Dolgris is fair. Dolgris is just. He has decreed that brother shall not do wrong by brother. If one has sinned against his fellow Dolgrimite, he must bring an accounting to bear. Witnesses must be called. Statements must be taken, and a selection of the victim and aggressor's peers must pass judgment. Else, if this is not to the satisfaction of both parties, they may instead engage in a sanctioned Battle of Blood. The victor will be declared just, and the loser executed."

"Tyranny of the strong." Unarin chuckled. "What a *noble* way of handling disputes."

"A metal worshiper like you could never comprehend the brilliance of our God." Gorzana said, unwilling to entertain Unarin's blasphemy.

Before long, they arrived inside Gorzana's personal throne room at the heart of the largest underground city. After striding past many different guards, they walked behind the throne into a secret antechamber.

This chamber was small, perhaps only big enough for five people to stand side by side; fewer if they were the size of the Matriarch. There was an altar depicting Dolgris's face at the scene, but it was just as vague and lacking in detail as all the other graven images Unarin had seen along the way.

"You have spoken to Dolgris before?" Unarin asked.

"Of course." Gorzana said, pride evident in her voice. "Few have had the opportunity. Cinculu is also one of them."

"Do you know what he looks like?" Unarin asked.

"I have not gazed upon my God's visage." Gorzana replied. "I am unworthy."

The corner of Unarin's mouth crept up, ever so slightly. He quickly stifled the urge to smirk and returned his face to a neutral resting position.

Gorzana walked over to the altar. She bowed before it for ten long minutes, praying with her palms clasped together to her God.

Eventually, a magical portal materialized. It was pitch-black, revealing a dimension of pure darkness on the other side. None who gazed upon it could obtain a hint of what lay beyond.

Gorzana stood up. She stared with deep respect and adoration at the portal.

"Dolgris awaits." She said, gesturing toward it.

"Great. I'll be on my way, then." Unarin said, casually striding forward. He stepped through the portal, and it closed behind him.

"Disrespectful bastard!" Cinculu hissed through clenched teeth. "We'll see how haughty he remains after coming face to face with our GOD!"

* * *

Unarin's eyes were exceptional. He could make out many minor details even in a pitch-black room deep underneath a planet's soil.

But inside Dolgris's Sanctum, his eyes were of no use. An intense darkness swallowed everything in absolute blackness. It was not ordinary darkness, but a domain that deliberately prevented mere mortals from seeing beyond their immediate vicinity. Even when Unarin waved his palm in front of his face, he couldn't see a shadow of its movement.

There was a quiet rumbling in the darkness. Unarin's keen ears easily picked up on the faint noise. But it was his nose that detected a most unusual odor inside this dark domain. He smelled what could only be described as burned, acrid flesh. Not burns caused by ordinary fire, but chemical burns caused by an extremely potent acid.

After a few moments of standing around waiting, Unarin loudly, and rudely, yawned.

"Ahh, goodness. Apologies. Are you quite done with all this pomp and ceremony, Dolgris? Are you ready to speak to this inferior mortal yet?"

In the blackness of the sanctum, a pair of even blacker eyes secretly looked down upon Unarin from high above. A snort rang out in the still air, drawing Unarin's unseeing gaze upward.

"**Weak little mortal. You think too highly of yourself.**"

The speaker was none other than Dolgris.

His voice was deep and bassy. It had a sort of grinding sensation to it, as if boulders were being rubbed together whenever he enunciated a syllable. It was rather unpleasant to listen to.

Unarin, of course, was not fazed. He merely looked up into the darkness, unable to see anything, with the same bored expression as before.

"You really think highly of yourself, Dolgris. A lauded Apex Cosmic, lording it over a species of idiotic mortals. You know the other Cosmics would laugh if they knew this was how you spent your days, don't you? I wonder what sort of pathetic form your body has taken to lower you to such a level."

Dolgris did not flare up with rage. He remained cool-headed in the face of Unarin's taunting.

"**A small creature with small thoughts. You came here rather confidently. Are you not afraid of me smiting you where you stand? You don't even have that Second Founder to protect you… not that she *could*.**"

"If you're going to kill me, just get it over with already." Unarin said, his fear lessening even further from its already nonexistent level. "I've lived a long life. Death, torture, whatever else doesn't bother me. At this point, my Empire is already on its way to ruin, so I've no fears of you destroying it, either. But I know the same is not true of *you*. You have a reason to live on. A need you must fill. And that need ensures you won't harm a tendril on my head."

Something loomed closer to Unarin in the darkness. He still could not tell what Dolgris's true form was, but he could *feel* the 'dark god' drawing his face closer.

"**I was correct in bringing you here, Unarin. You are not like these other small-minded and foolish mortals. You know how to bend to circumstance, yet you do not fear death. That makes you an exceptionally valuable pawn. But do tell, what 'need' is it that I need your help to fulfill? Would you be so kind as to illuminate this God on the subject?**"

"As an Apex Cosmic, you only have two things that give your life purpose." Unarin said calmly. "Either you choose to be one of the many Apex Cosmics that guard the Milky Way, or you take up the position of the galaxy's Ruler. Since there are no other Apex Cosmics out there, you're in the unique position of choosing whichever one suits your fancy. Even better, we currently have no Ruler. That leaves a nice, juicy opening for you to pursue. Life Beyond Eternity. It's quite enticing, I must admit."

"**For a mortal, you know a great deal about matters between Cosmics.**" Dolgris said softly. "**No doubt the Psions have kept you well informed.**"

"I know that Akasha's Game is about to begin." Unarin stated. "Wars between galaxies. The Milky Way is ripe for the plundering. If we don't elevate a Ruler soon, we're certain to perish to a greater power. Our forces cannot compare to those of Andromeda, Cat's Eye, Messier, or countless others. It stands to reason that uplifting a powerful Cosmic to Ruler would benefit us all greatly. And one as noble as yourself has no reason to bother with the mundanities of managing mortals."

"**Hehe.**" Dolgris laughed sinisterly.

He didn't reply to Unarin's prompting.

Unarin smiled up at the darkness. His was an expression born of knowing he already held his opponent's strengths and weaknesses within the palm of his hand.

"You want one thing, Dolgris. You wish for the Milky Way to revere you so that you can ascend to the position of Ruler. I can make that happen. The Dolgrimites cannot."

"**You think too highly of yourself.**" Dolgris said. "**You are not as all-knowing as you believe. I have already conversed with the Dark Ones. I have plenty of room to cut a deal with them. Why should I try to become Ruler of a weak, fragile, useless galaxy like this one? Even if I Ascend, I have no powerful subjects at my beck and call. Dosena was not bad for a Cosmic, but she was only a Middle Cosmic. Now she is useless. The other options are thin and murky at best.**"

"I see." Unarin said. "So if you sell out the Milky Way to the Dark Ones... what? They will give you control of a different galaxy? Can such a good deal truly exist? Why would they give you command of a galaxy with more powerful Cosmics in exchange for one as weak as the Milky Way? Are you an imbecile?"

"**Watch your tone.**" Dolgris snarled, a flicker of irritation in his voice. "**Speak snidely once more, and mere words will not be able to protect you from my wrath.**"

"Right, right, yes. You're going to kill me if I upset you. I should have realized your feelings were sensitive." Unarin said lightly.

Suddenly, from the darkness, Dolgris loomed closer than ever. The outline of his face emerged from the shadows, revealing himself to Unarin. His eyes twitched with barely contained rage. His face contorted into the vicious, bestial expression of a predator eyeing its prey...

And Unarin's mood finally lifted. In that moment, he obtained exactly what he was looking for.

"**You DARE speak out again?!**" Dolgris roared. "**I will KILL-!**"

"So you're a dragon." Unarin interrupted, looking at the face of the Dolgrimites' 'god' for the first time ever. "Everything makes sense now. I theorized you might be one, but I wasn't entirely certain until this exact moment. Based on recent clues I've obtained, you've been hiding within Grimvolas's secret dimension for a very, very long time, *Dolgris*."

The dark dragon's eyes widened slightly. He suddenly realized the error he had made and started to pull back, only to realize the pointlessness of such an action.

"**You... you tricked me. You wished to confirm this God's identity? Is that why you came here?**"

"That's right." Unarin said. "I've been perusing the ancient records of many different species, but none were as interesting as those belonging to the humans... or more specifically, the *angels*. It seems there was a terrible war, many eons ago. The dragons were thought to be exterminated. Your apparent deaths were not as complete as the Archangels believed. In addition to yourself, there was another dragon hiding on Earth named Leviathan. Was he your beloved baby brother? Or your older brother? Could you clarify for me?"

Dolgris glowered at Unarin. The serpent's eyes narrowed as he considered what to do next.

"**I have hid my face for eons. Not out of fear, but necessity.**" Dolgris said slowly. "**Long ago, I suffered an injury most grievous. I hid on Grimvolas and submerged myself to avoid detection. I believed that if the Archangels sensed me, they would exterminate me without question. When my mother passed, I felt her power enter me. When my final brother fell, I also experienced his power. But even so, my injuries remained.**"

Dolgris's eyes flickered with blatant hatred.

"**Those *foul* Archangels. Protectors of the galaxy, they called themselves. But in truth, they were bloodthirsty villains. They may be dead now, but the wound they dealt upon me weakened me to the point I could not wield the full power of an Apex Cosmic.**"

Dolgris spoke frankly, which somewhat surprised Unarin. He thought he would have to do more coaxing to get the information from the dragon, but it turned out Dolgris was quite interested in conversing with an intelligent entity on the First Founder's level.

"**I am unable at present to acquire the strength of a Ruler, Unarin.**" Dolgris admitted. "**Even if I met all the requirements, my body would not possess the ability to Ascend further. My last hope was extinguished recently. I am... lost. I do not know what actions I can take to recover my full strength. Only by making a deal with the Dark Ones can I regain my former glory.**"

"The recent loss you suffered." Unarin said calmly. "That was when Mephisto's dragon bones were hurled into a black hole?"

Dolgris hesitated.

When he spoke next, his tone made Unarin's ears perk up.

"**Yes.**"

It was a lie. Even if Dolgris was an Apex Cosmic, he could not easily deceive Unarin's social acumen. The First Founder had spent millions of years learning to deceive and to see through deceptions by greater and lesser life-forms. Demila temporarily fooled him, but only because of their long-shared history and Unarin's belief that he knew her too well for her to lie to him. Other Sentients could not claim such a lofty victory over him.

But if Dolgris *was* lying, then what was he lying about?

Unarin did not press the matter. He opted to play stupid and take Dolgris's words at face value.

"It seems your situation is more complex than I expected." Unarin said, after a moment of thought. "Whatever your motivations may be, you are ultimately a denizen of this galaxy. Dosena spent millions of cycles attempting to rise through the ranks and become an Apex Cosmic. She failed. It is unlikely we are going to acquire such a Cosmic in our Empire any time soon. As such, I am eager to assist you in acquiring the power you need to take the final step and become a Ruler. Are you in dire need of dragon bones to empower yourself? Also known as 'Living Moldanium'? If so, I can take drastic steps to procure it from various sources. Living Moldanium is a precious resource, but alternatives exist."

Dolgris's eyes seemed to dim ever so slightly. "**I had my eyes on a certain sentient. You knew him as the Wordsmith. He seemed to possess a power that could have rebuilt my body. Unfortunately, he perished, along with his clone. If you can find a way to create a new clone of the Wordsmith, that would suit my purposes. As for Living Moldanium… if you have processed it into a new form, it is useless to me. Only intact dragon bones will be useful in repairing my body. Else, we must wait and pray I am able to repair the damage on my own, as I have been doing since time immemorial. Though my progress is slow, I am making minor headway in healing my wounds.**"

"I am able to clone the Wordsmith, but his supernatural powers will not persist." Unarin said. "My Empire has attempted to clone Enhanced Entities on many occasions, but we always fail to replicate their extraordinary qualities. I'm sure you can imagine why."

"**Duplicating the Uniqueness of an individual is impossible.**" Dolgris said. "**There are many Sentients, Cosmics, and Rulers who desire to devour the Uniqueness of Sentients and galaxies alike. Doing so would allow their abilities to progress... but alas, soul manipulation is the one method that will always cause terrible damage to those foolish enough to try it.**"

Unarin's eyes flickered. He privately wondered if this was more than just an idle thought. Had Dolgris attempted soul manipulation in the past? Could that be the real reason his body was injured and he hadn't yet healed it?

Naturally, he did not state this thought.

He continued to converse with Dolgris for a while. Eventually, the two of them came to an understanding of one another.

"**You are a fascinating mortal. I sense within you a spark of greatness even more impressive than those I have seen in Rulers. Killing you would truly be a shame. I shall allow you to continue ruling your Empire as you see fit. As for the foolish Dolgrimites... I will give you a method to contact me. Feel free to dispatch them to worlds as you wish. Exterminating this 'Plague' should be a top priority. Its origins are rather... *frightening*.**"

Unarin's eyes shone. He met Dolgris's gaze.

"You know of the origin of the Plague?"

"**How can I not? But telling you of it will reap no advantage. Simply be aware that this galactic abomination is older than you know. Eliminating it from various worlds is quite simple for my children to do, but eliminating the source... that cannot come to pass unless I regain my full power. The origin point of the Plague is too mighty for the Milky Way to defeat...**"

Dolgris waved a claw, dismissing Unarin. The First Founder respectfully bowed his head for a moment, then uttered a quiet farewell. After he was dismissed, he stepped

through a portal Dolgris had opened, arriving back in the Matriarch's Throne Antechamber.

There, Gorzana and Cinculu awaited, smug smiles on their faces. They believed in their heart of hearts Unarin had definitely had the wits scared out of him by their great God.

Thus, when Unarin returned, his expression the same as before, they both quaked with worry. What had their God told him?

"Dolgris is quite an interesting fellow." Unarin said casually. "We held a dialogue most fascinating. Feel free to pay him a visit soon. He will relay the contents of our discussion to you. As for me, I am going to return to Volgarius by myself. Thank you kindly for bringing me here."

Cinculu gawked. When he had spoken to Dolgris in the past, he had left the room trembling in fear and adulation. How was Unarin able to remain standing with nary a hint of fear on his face? He must be bluffing!

"You!" Cinculu growled.

"Yes?" Unarin asked, his expression unmoved.

Cinculu clenched his jaw together. He was silent for a few seconds, then he looked away.

"I shall escort you to your shuttle." Cinculu eventually said.

"Oh, most excellent." Unarin replied. "I always enjoy our conversations. Be sure to entertain me along the way."

If eyes could shoot lasers, the look Cinculu gave Unarin would surely melt his body to slag...

Part 677: Chrona's Biggest Loser

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

A little over two weeks had passed in the outside galaxy, but years had passed inside Chrona. With its time dilation having increased to nearly 300x realspace, that meant a bit over 17 years had passed for Chrona's denizens.

Chrona itself had expanded. Not only in population, but in size as well. Kar and Blinker continued to have children, and the general human worries about 'incest' were not enough to stop their various children from pairing together. Thus, the population had started to balloon at an increasingly fast rate, forcing more construction and more expansion toward the edge of Chrona.

Chrona was a lot like the Labyrinth. It grew based on its internal life energy. Unlike Jason's much more successful secondary realm, Aevum, Chrona did not have a great quantity of life inside of it, but all its life forms were qualitatively powerful. Seeing that the teleporters leading to the outside world were growing increasingly stressed by the strengthening temporal distortions, Fiona had long ago taken matters into her own hands. She teleported various non-sentient creatures and beasts from different planets across the Milky Way into Chrona. She forcefully created a natural food chain, using predators and prey to balance each other out.

Much like Aevum, Fiona, Blinker, and Rebecca had worked together to build a huge barrier around the central city. It was, unfortunately, not as formidable as the one Jason made inside Aevum, but it was powerful enough to keep Chrona's newly added wildlife out.

They did not have access to Genesis Ichor. They did not have a way to rapidly evolve the creatures inside Chrona. But that was never their purpose anyway; they only wished to ensure they had a stable food supply in the event the replicators broke down or some other catastrophe happened.

Fiona was growing more worried by the year. She could easily see that the time where they lost contact with the outer galaxy would be upon them soon. Already, the Spynet had lost 15% of its viewscreen connections, notably those closest to powerful Psions, Cosmics,

and other supernatural entities. Their innate energy fields broke down the magical connections between Chrona and its microscopic spy drones.

Communicating with the outside world was also growing increasingly difficult. Previously, Fiona could reliably send messages to the Phoenix, who would transmit them through Jepthath to the rest of humanity. But sometimes, she wasn't able to connect to the Phoenix for days at a time when her transmitters broke down. She had to rely on sporadic data-bursts more and more often, hoping they could transmit through the temporal interference to reach the outside galaxy.

It was on one of these random days when Fiona quietly sighed. She was walking around a beautiful garden cultivated by some of the Crocodile children, who enjoyed doing so because it made their mother, the Matriarch, as well as their father, the Patriarch, happy.

The garden was a large circular area with multiple inner rings. Her nephew, Sir Lorent, walked around in a body seemingly just as corporeal as her own. He held Shana's hand in his own.

"Aunt Fiona." Lorent said, his eyes brightening at her presence. "I trust you're doing well?"

Fiona didn't immediately reply. She sighed again.

"...Yes. I suppose so." She muttered lamely.

"It seems the situation is worsening." Lorent said softly. "What is our worst case scenario?"

"Runaway temporal acceleration. Spatial collapse." Fiona said, her tone grave. "If we're lucky, we'll only end up trapped inside an infinitely accelerating dimension that infinitely isolates us from the outside galaxy. Thousands, hundreds of thousands, even millions of years could pass for us for each day that passes outside. It's a frightening thought."

"Living space will become a problem..." Lorent said. "Especially with the way Kar and Blinker's progeny love to rear children. Oh! Aunt, I do have some good news!"

Lorent gestured down to Shana. "Sugarplum here came up with a great idea to solve our material production deficiency!"

Shana blushed. She liked her adopted uncle's nickname for her.

"Uncle Lorent can make metal with his paintings!" Shana declared. "And wood, and string, and lots of other stuff!"

She still looked like a child, but years of socializing with Lorent had done wonders for her mental development. Unless Jason reappeared and used his magic, she would be forced to stay in a spiritual child body, but at least she was immortal, like her uncle and the other Chrona denizens.

"That's a fantastic breakthrough!" Fiona said. She smiled tiredly. "I wish I'd thought of it years ago. I just have so much on my mind, these days."

"I imagine you do." Lorent said. He smiled, but the expression felt somewhat disheartened. "I've been trying new things with my painting. I think I might make a breakthrough soon. Shana's powers especially work well with mine."

"They do?" Fiona asked. She was genuinely clueless. She loved her nephew dearly, but she just didn't have time to spend with him or others, since there was always so much stuff breaking down. If she and Rebecca didn't keep on top of the technology failures, the damage would compound and Chrona would regress to the dark ages.

"Shana's power allows her to boost the magical abilities of other entities, particularly nonliving ones. Artifacts!" Lorent explained. "I've been trying to paint increasingly more complex objects in the hopes I can make an artifact like the ones Jason used to make. If my plans succeed, we could have a real breakthrough!"

"That's wonderful, Lorent!" Fiona said, feeling herself cheer up a little. "If there's anything I can do to help, just let me know."

"I'd rather you didn't overwork yourself any more than you already do." Lorent said seriously. "But yes, there's one small thing I need. Could you allow me access to Jason's storage bunker where he kept all those artifacts he was working on? Maybe I can learn more about artifacts if I study them."

Fiona's smile broke. She visibly faltered, then looked off to the side.

"I... I don't know..."

"Aunt... I know you loved the man, and you think he might still be alive... but we have to be realistic." Lorent said gently. "If he does come back, I doubt he'll be mad I touched his stuff. I'll be extra careful not to damage anything. And if he doesn't return, then...?"

"I understand." Fiona said quietly. She glanced wistfully into the distance, where a mausoleum containing Jason and Phoebe's bodies had been erected. Having retrieved them from Realspace after Gressil's revelation, Fiona had taken great care to preserve their bodies inside cryostasis pods. She couldn't bring herself to believe Jason and Phoebe were truly dead, but she knew in the darkest parts of her heart neither of them would ever return.

After a long pause, Fiona slowly nodded. "Alright. I'll... give you access. Please treat Jason's artifacts with care. I should let Timothy see them as well. It's not right that I've denied him this part of his father for so long."

"Timothy..." Lorent said, looking off at a distant house and sighing. "That boy never comes out and visits anyone. He's holed himself up in there. I worry about him."

"He's lonely. We can't blame him." Fiona said. "The only friends he has his age are crocodiles. All the rest of us are old people and thousand-year-old Psions. Sometimes I wish I'd brought more humans into Chrona permanently, but instead I shunted them all back out into Realspace following Tarus II's destruction. Phoebe's baby boy has to grow up alone because of me."

"Everyone has their problems." Lorent said. "At least he wasn't raised from birth to be Mordred's Butcher, right?"

Fiona lifelessly chuckled. She gave her nephew a wry smile. "You shouldn't joke about such things."

She chatted with Lorent and Shana for a while longer, then turned and made her way toward the distant house that she nominally lived in, but which she rarely visited. Fiona never required sleep, and her duties were constant and ever-expanding, so she rarely returned home. She spent a depressingly small amount of time with Timothy as a result.

Timothy was not Fiona's son. But she treated him like hers. Timothy had long ago learned the truth of his birth parents, and grappled with their deaths. Since Fiona was a clone of the mother he never met, he treated her as if she were his blood mother and never resented her for it.

But Fiona knew Timothy wasn't entirely okay. He lived in his room, playing video games, watching movies, and was obviously suffering from a deep loneliness-inspired bout of depression.

Sometimes Fiona worried the boy might even grow so despondent he wished to end his life. Nothing scared her more than that possibility.

Fiona walked over to her home. She quietly pushed the door open, but didn't hear any noise inside.

"Timothy? Are you asleep?" She asked out loud. She looked around the living room, but all the lights were off. Eventually, she noticed a flicker of light down the hall, originating from Timothy's room.

Unsure if he was awake or asleep, Fiona crept down the hallway noiselessly. She turned the corner and looked in his room, where she saw Timothy sitting in the easy chair in front of his television. He was leaning back heavily in the chair, and his hands were in his lap. His back was to the door, so he didn't notice his mother spying on him.

Fiona blinked. Timothy wasn't watching a movie or playing a game. Instead, he was watching a recently recorded video from Realspace. It was a video recorded by the Spynet... and it showed a familiar girl Fiona had seen several times over the years. She was Benajmin Brown's daughter, Lily Brown, and she was bathing in a tub inside her house on Sharmur. Periodically, she splashed water on her bare, ample breasts...

"TIMOTHY EDWARD HIRO!" Fiona shrieked, nearly scaring herself with the volume she suddenly projected. "Just what in the HELL do you think you're doing?!"

Timothy practically jumped out of his skin. He leaped out of his chair like a cat that had its tail stomped on. His pants had been pulled down, and when he turned to see his mother standing there, he was clearly stricken with horror as he quickly lowered his hands to cover himself up.

"M-Mom?! What are you- ahh! Knock first! No, wait, this isn't what it looks like!"

"It's EXACTLY what it looks like!" Fiona screamed, quickly whirling around, not wanting to see her son doing something so foul. Her face turned crimson. "Using the Spynet as a peep-show?! You should be ashamed of yourself! Put your goddamn pants on and get out in the living room, young man!"

She stormed out of the room, flipped the lights on in the living room, and clawed at her face and eyes. Here Fiona was, all worried about her son, but the little rat bastard was being a goddamn pervert when he thought nobody was looking!

After half a minute, Timothy awkwardly shuffled out of his room. He stared at the floor as if it were the most interesting thing in the world, then came to a stop at the other end of the living room.

"It's... it's not what it seems, mom..." He lied lamely. "I... I just..."

Fiona took a few moments to inhale and exhale deeply. Despite not technically being a corporeal being anymore, she still reflexively lived like one. She regained her center of calm, then slowly turned around to face her obviously extremely-embarrassed son.

"No lies, Timothy." Fiona said calmly. "I momentarily lost my temper, but I'm not angry anymore. I just want an explanation."

Timothy stared at the floor for an entire minute, uncertain of what to say. He bit his lip, then finally looked up at his mother.

"This... I just... I was watching her all day... because she was so beautiful... and then she went home and... I kept watching."

Fiona remained stone-faced. "Do you do this often?"

Timothy slowly shook his head. "Not often. But sometimes. I know it's wrong. But... the wrongness... feels good."

Fiona's heart became heavy.

I've been failing as a mother. I raised a voyeur and didn't even notice.

But not long after, her thoughts cleared up.

Of course he's a voyeur. Timothy doesn't have any human friends his age. He only knows how to socialize with the Crocodiles, but they probably treat him like the odd one out. He watches humans in Realspace because he longs to go there. But he can't, because he's been raised in a time-accelerated environment since infancy. If he goes out there, he'll die...

"Mom, it's not that bad." Timothy said lamely. "It's not like she knew I was watching. What's the harm?"

"Spying on someone else without their knowledge is not okay. Even if they don't know, it's still crossing a serious ethical boundary." Fiona explained.

"But mom! You spy on people all the time!" Timothy protested. "All day long, sometimes! What, it's different just because I was looking at a naked girl? Where's the

consistency?"

"Don't get smart with me, young man." Fiona bit back. "I do *not* spy on people during their private moments, especially not for my own pleasure."

She continued to stare at him angrily, her arms crossed, until a few moments had passed. For the hundredth time that day, Fiona sighed tiredly. She might be a spiritual life form, but her mind felt slow and groggy.

"It's my fault." Fiona whispered, looking away. "I should have brought more humans here. Your only friends are crocodiles and Psions. Your only interaction with other humans involve me and the Spynet. It's not fair. I'm sorry I've done such a poor job."

Timothy's heart dropped. "Mom, come on. Don't say stuff like that. It's not your fault. It's me. I'm a weirdo and a creep. I'll stop doing this peeping stuff, okay? Just don't blame yourself..."

He slowly walked over, then reached out his arms and hugged Fiona tightly.

"I'm sorry, mom. I won't do it again. It was wrong, okay? It was wrong of me..."

Fiona hugged him back. She leaned her head against his shoulder and kissed his cheek.

"You're a good boy, Timothy. I'm sorry I can't be there for you as much as you need."

Timothy looked past his adoptive mother's face. He stared at the wall guiltily, feeling terrible about everything that had just occurred.

"I'll... I'll delete everything, okay, mom?"

"No. I will." Fiona said, pulling away. She narrowed her eyes at him. "A simple apology isn't good enough this time. I'm going to make sure it's all gone, and I'm going to close off your access to the Spynet. You've broken my trust, and it will take a lot of work to mend it back."

Timothy lowered his eyes. "Yes, mom."

She forced him to stay in the living room, then she hesitantly walked back into his room. After gritting her teeth, she pulled up a keyboard and started quickly looking through his hard drives.

"God..." She groaned under her breath. "So much footage. Wait, isn't this *Samantha*? His own *aunt*?! I guess he hasn't seen her since he was a baby, but still! And Kiari...

several succubi... are those kobold girls? Harpies? Orcs?? They're barely even humanoid!"

A weird expression crossed over Fiona's face.

"...At least he's not racist. A minor comfort."

Timothy's wretched spank-bank turned out to be way bigger than she expected. After Fiona deleted it all, she put on several layers of password protection to ensure he couldn't access the Spynet again. Then she paused.

"I mean, he's a growing boy. Should I really delete everything? Is it bad if I do that? I wish Jason were here. He'd know more about this than me... it feels wrong to leave him with nothing, I mean, he has *needs* right? Right?? It isn't as if he can meet them the normal way."

Fiona wanted to pull the skin off her face. She was so grossed out and disturbed, but at the same time she wasn't a man, so she wasn't sure what was normal versus abnormal. She only knew from her own perspective what felt like a violation.

"At least he isn't creeping on any of the crocodile girls up here." Fiona mumbled. "Or would that be better? Is it good if he likes crocodile girls? Is he respecting their boundaries? Or maybe he's grossed out by them? Should I ask? No way! I'd rather die than talk about something so sickening!"

Fiona finished her work. She walked back out into the living room and stared at her son evenly. He met her gaze.

"Timothy. Do you want to travel to Realspace?"

Timothy started to nod, but then looked away and shrugged.

"I don't know. I'm used to things in Chrona. Outside seems... scary. The whole Plague thing freaks me out, and I'm not good at talking to people either, so everyone would probably just laugh at me. Or they'd compare me to my dad. That's what everyone *here* does."

"What! People don't do that!" Fiona protested. "I think you're in your head too much, Timothy."

"Yeah they do." Timothy said sullenly. "My dad was a legendary Hero, but I'm nothing special at all. I'm just a normal guy. No powers. Nothing special about me. Everyone's disappointed."

"You're not even eighteen yet." Fiona pointed out. "Most Trueborn Heroes don't develop their abilities until they turn eighteen. Only a few outliers like Joan of Arc exist, and they're the exception that proves the rule."

Fiona threw her hands up helplessly. "Besides, even if you never develop any powers, so what? Neither me nor your mother had any powers, and we helped humanity out a lot. I mean, we did get a little help by interacting with Solomon's Crown, but that merely boosted our intelligence a bit. If you study hard and live out your life here, you can become incredibly smart even without powers!"

Timothy looked at his mom with dismal eyes. "I'm not immortal like you, or Kar, or any of the others. I only have a hundred short years to live, and likely less. Not even a year in the outside world. The Immortality Station dad made on Tarus II is gone. With so short a time, how can I possibly make a difference? You just don't get it. I'm *useless*."

Timothy pulled his feet up into the chair and wrapped his arms around his knees. He always did that when he was feeling depressed. It was his way of retreating into himself.

Fiona lightly licked her lips. She wanted to protest, to tell him he wasn't useless, but her words were not an argument based on factual data. They were purely an appeal to emotion. She could tell him he had the potential for greatness, but those words would fall flat if she didn't have a way to back them up.

"I... well, I actually came here to tell you that I gave permission to your uncle to go inside your father's warehouse." Fiona said, slightly changing the subject. "Lorent wants to start learning about artifacts. I thought you'd want to hang out with him and aunt Shana, maybe see the gizmos and gadgets your father made. Who knows? Maybe there's something really useful in there. Rebecca will be there to help you out as well. She was quite familiar with Jason's creations back in the day."

Timothy continued to stare ahead glumly. He didn't look particularly inspired. Eventually, he did nod.

"Yeah. Sounds good, mom. I guess I'll take a look later."

Timothy..." Fiona said quietly, but she didn't know what else to say.

It was clear Timothy was still feeling deeply ashamed about what happened earlier. He had a difficult time meeting her eyes. That awkwardness in turn made Fiona uncomfortable. She was effectively a single mother with no father around for Timothy to

learn from. There was Lorent, but he was usually doing things with Shana. Kar existed, but he had hundreds of his own kids to worry about. There were male Psions around, but they were so utterly alien that they had no conception of human developmental needs. All the other humans and human-like figures in Chrona were women.

Fiona decided she would just have to talk to Lorent about her son later.

"I'm... I'm going to go." Fiona said. "Did you want anything? Maybe I can cook you some food before I leave?"

"No need. I'm fine." Timothy mumbled.

"Right." Fiona said.

She hesitated, then walked over and kissed the top of his head. She wrung her fingers together in consternation as she looked down at him, but he continued to stare off into the distance.

"I love you, Timothy." Fiona said quietly.

He hesitated before nodding and saying, "Love you too, mom."

Fiona sighed for the millionth time that day. She turned and walked out of the living room, then the house, leaving Timothy behind.

After his mom left, Timothy continued to stare at the wall for a long time.

"Stupid." He muttered. "Getting caught like that. I'm a disappointment, like I've always been. I should just crawl in a hole and die."

Timothy rubbed his wrist. He rocked back and forth in his chair, then sighed.

The situation was worse than Fiona knew. Every day was like torture for him. Timothy felt the gazes of others on his back. He felt their eyes on him, subtly laughing, mocking him for being a pathetic loser.

And now even his mother was disgusted by him. He had never felt so low and unlovable in all his life.

"My dad wouldn't have been so pathetic." Timothy muttered. "He'd be embarrassed to have a loser like me for a son."

Timothy had never known Jason, but he had rewatched several of Jason's most stunning moments, particularly his battle against Hope, thanks to the Spynet. Seeing his father heroically defeat his clone and win an overwhelming victory, only to be

backstabbed by Creator Demila was a thrilling but tragic set of happenings that always left Timothy's eyes wet with tears.

Seeing his father die was agonizing. Jason may have revived, but the man who came back was incapable of withstanding the evil machinations of Emperor Gressil. Timothy wanted nothing more than to rip Gressil apart with his bare hands, but without any powers, it was about as likely to happen as any other ordinary human defeating an Emperor.

After sulking for a while in his depression, Timothy eventually got up and shuffled back to his room. He was surprised to see that his mother hadn't grounded him and taken away all his entertainment, but he knew she always felt extremely guilty about not being able to spend much time with him. That was why his betrayal of her trust hurt him as much as it did her.

He sat in his chair and turned on a random movie. It was a romantic comedy filmed during the 1900s era of ancient Earth. Something about a man falling in love with a woman through postcards. He wasn't really paying attention.

"Man. What am I going to do with my life?" Timothy wondered to himself. "I should call Ferral over. He's always easy to talk to. Maybe he can help me out."

Timothy decided that when he felt better in a few hours, he'd do just that.

Part 678: The King Network

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

[Brother Timothy. It is most unusual for you to ask me to spend Relations Building Time with you during the third cycle of a week. Usually you prefer to do so on the first or seventh cycle.]

Learner Ferral, formerly Initiator Ferral, was one of the few dozen Psions who had been pulled to Chrona by Jason Hiro years and years earlier. He had reached the 2nd Level at a speed somewhat slower than his peers, and was not considered an especially speedy developing Psion. He was rather lazy, and he preferred to spend his time admiring artwork, looking upon the Milky Way's wonders through the Spynet, or spending time with Timothy... *gaming*.

Timothy had pulled up an ancient Earth Xbox with an extra controller for Ferral. The two of them often played classic games like Halo 1 and 2 together, with Ferral especially enjoying all the fun and beautiful scenery in the game, as well as its action-packed setpieces and general combat flow. He might not be much of a dedicated fighter among his fellow Psions, but fake virtual game points always roused his interest.

"I just wanted to hang out." Timothy said, his voice somewhat glum. "My... my mom caught me doing something... something I'm ashamed about. I didn't know who else to talk to."

Ferral sat beside Timothy on the couch.

[I contemplate and I comprehend.] Ferral said. [How shameful was the action you were performing? You do not need to say if you do not wish to.]

Timothy grimaced. He looked at the TV, which was currently on the title screen of a *Mario Kart Double Dash*.

"I was... I had downloaded lots of different videos from the Spynet... I was peeping on girls and mom found out. She was pissed."

Ferral looked at him with a completely blank face. [Peeping. This word. I do not comprehend.]

"Well, I was looking at them when they were naked, or doing other private things..." Timothy explained.

[I still do not understand.] Ferral said, his alien mind uncomprehending of the nuances of human behavior. [How does this correlate with shame?]

"Because I was... pleasuring myself to them!" Timothy finally spat. His face turned deep red. If he had said this to another guy his age, he'd probably already have crawled in a hole and died, but Ferral was so oblivious that he *still* didn't fully understand.

[Ah, you must be referring to self-sexual satisfaction.] Ferral said, remembering a biological textbook his teacher had made him read regarding human sexuality. [According to my understanding, reproduction and the act of copulation are considered extremely pleasurable to most Terrans. Self gratification is also a behavior considered within normal parameters. I still do not understand what is shameful about your actions.]

Timothy's face turned a shade of gray. "...Never mind. You wouldn't understand. Point is, my mom caught me, and now I feel like shit. I'm so embarrassed I could jump off a cliff."

[I highly advise against doing so.] Ferral stated. [You are not a Psion. Without the ability to fly, extreme bodily injury or even death could result from such an action.]

Timothy looked at Ferral with the strangest expression he'd ever made in his life.

"Uh. Yeah. Good point, Ferral. I hadn't thought if it that way. Look, let's just play some games, alright?"

[I very much enjoy playing Video Games.] Ferral said, his eyes lighting up with interest. [We are going to play the racing game with the colorful humans and animals riding karts, then?]

"Yeah. Mario Kart." Timothy said.

* * *

An hour passed. Two hours. Three...

He slowly forgot about his worries as he had fun playing games with Ferral, swapping out one title after another as time passed. Ferral didn't enjoy sticking to one game much and preferred to jump around. It seemed he derived a lot of dopamine from playing new things.

"This is a single-player game called Elder Scrolls Oblivion." Timothy explained. "It's a sequel to Morrowind. You remember that game, right? It's singleplayer though so we'll have to pass the controller back and forth."

[Most excellent!] Ferral exclaimed. [I very much enjoy these open world exploration games. There is much enjoyability to be found in exploring new locales and animals and people. If the galaxy wasn't overrun by the Plague, I would love to travel around someday, visiting all the worlds I cannot enjoy now.]

"Well, mom says the Dolgrimites are capable of beating back the Plague." Timothy said slowly. "Who knows? Maybe you'll be able to go sightseeing someday. Unfortunately, we're not going to see it unless we solve the time dilation dilemma."

[A high level Temporal Psion might be able to decelerate Chrona's time flow.] Ferral said. [Or perhaps Queen Blinker can use her fairy magic? I suppose your mother might also be able to develop a technological solution along with Rebecca's help.]

"Yeah. Maybe." Timothy muttered.

He didn't add anything else.

Before long, he and Ferral were playing through the early stages of Oblivion. They escaped the dungeon and entered the wider world of Tamriel, and as always, Ferral was most engaged with the early exploration parts of the game.

[I find leveling up and allotting my stats to be cerebrally pleasurable.] Ferral said. [It is fun to watch my character grow in power. I wish real life was like that. Then meditating and increasing my Psionic Power would not be so dreadfully boring.]

Timothy nodded. "That's for sure. Still, there's something to be said for hard work and gradual payoffs over time. When you look at yourself from a year ago and the you of now, don't you enjoy feeling that you have progressed?"

Ferral shrugged. A decidedly human movement.

[I suppose you could state the facts in such a manner. But on the cycle-by-cycle perception of time, I am unable to detect any real progress. Having a screen tell me that my intellect increased or my strength improved would be monumentally more engaging.]

Timothy couldn't argue with that. "Did you know that back on Earth, they had games that were called 'Massively Multiplayer Online RPGs'? Thousands, even millions of people

would play on the same server all at once. Leveling up together, adventuring together, killing monsters and completing quests together..."

[Why don't we develop one ourselves?] Ferral suddenly asked, looking at Timothy with deep intent. [It doesn't have to be perfect. We could code a game together, draw the artwork, and make something for all the people of Chrona to enjoy.]

"I don't know..." Timothy mumbled. "The crocodiles aren't into my dad's games. I've tried inviting a few of them over to play with me. One of them broke a controller when he lost a life. Your fellow Psions don't seem interested, either. Doesn't seem we'd have much of an audience."

[Technically, there already does exist such a game.] Ferral pointed out. [The Queen Network, developed by Blinker and the Black Queen, Amelia Greyjoy. It allows players to connect their digital consciousnesses into it to develop their fighting skills. Have you ever entered it before?]

Timothy shook his head. "First time I'm hearing about it."

[We still have a transmitter that can connect to the network.] Ferral said. [Unfortunately, due to the time dilation, the network has destabilized over time and lost quantum cohesion. We'd need to repair it before we could reconnect. The interesting thing about the Queen Network is, it allows people from Realspace to connect with people inside Chrona by temporarily accelerating their cerebral state to Chrona's speed! Thus, they can engage with us for short micro-burst durations without experiencing mental harm.]

Timothy's eyes sparkled. "So we could talk to people in Realspace with the Queen Network if we fixed it?"

[Yes, but the only people capable of repairing it are your mother, Rebecca, and Blinker. The first two are always busy. Blinker does not seem to have much interest.]

Timothy snorted. "Why don't I take a look? Maybe I can fix it. Can you show me the way?"

Ferral paused. [Yes... but... the transmitter is currently stored inside your father's warehouse. Your mother has designated that area a restricted zone.]

"She just told me I could go in there, when we spoke earlier." Timothy said. "Let's go take a look. Worst case scenario, we'll just come back here and waste our lives away

playing video games again."

[You always have such a way with words.] Ferral sarcastically praised.

* * *

Not long afterward, Timothy and Ferral made their way over to Jason's old warehouse. It was located next to his mausoleum, and Timothy stopped outside to look up at the statue of Jason and Phoebe, hugging each other closely as they stood together, looking into each other's eyes. This particular statue had been chiseled ten years earlier by a pair of talented crocodile artisans.

Timothy always stopped to look up at his father, larger than life, towering a hundred feet in the air.

He never felt he could measure up to the legendary Wordsmith.

With a soft sigh, Timothy walked over to the warehouse. There was a palm scanner next to the door, and he placed his hand on it. The door unlocked, and Timothy widened his eyes. "Mom really did unlock it for me..."

He and Ferral waited for the rusty door to slide open. In truth, the warehouse wasn't fortified, so if one of the Psions had wanted to break in, they could have done so with ease. Out of respect for the Wordsmith, they did not.

Once the large door slid to the side, Timothy noticed that the lights were already on inside. He entered the warehouse, where he found shelves upon shelves of seemingly random objects, weapons, armor, all laying on shelves, neatly organized with labels denoting their contents.

"Timothy? Is that you?"

A voice called out from inside. Timothy found his uncle Lorent inside, admiring a short dagger, while Shana was standing beside him, hefting a comically large sledgehammer. Surprisingly, she was holding it with great ease. She made it look like a foam toy.

"Uncle Lorent." Timothy said, rubbing the back of his head. "Ahh, mom said I could come here. Me and Ferral were bored, so I thought..."

"No need to explain." Lorent said with a smile. "Your old man and I weren't especially close, but I thought he was a stand up guy. You're almost eighteen, so it's about time you took a look through his stuff. Who knows? Maybe you'll find something useful in here."

Timothy nodded. He smiled at the little girl beside Lorent. "Hey, Aunt Shana."

"Hi Timothy." Shana said. "I found a big hammer."

"You sure did..." Timothy said, eyeing the sledgehammer that was much bigger than his spiritual aunt. "Say, do either of you know where the Queen Network connection device is located?"

Lorent scratched his chin. He hemmed and hawed for a moment, looking around at the various shelves.

"I'm... not sure. This is my first time coming in here since your dad... well, and since then, Rebecca came through and sorted everything. I don't know how she sorted all his stuff. Best you just take a look around."

Ferral's eyes lit up. [I shall assist in this game of scavenger hunt!]

The young Psion eagerly zipped over to the closest shelf. He started pulling boxes and crates down, rummaging through them while psionically humming the theme song of some video game that had gotten stuck in his head. Another decidedly human trait he had picked up over the years.

Timothy, meanwhile, mimicked Ferral. He walked over to a shelf off to the left, where he finally got a closer look at the labels of various items.

STORAGE RINGS (INCOMPLETE PROTOTYPES)

RUNECARVING - MISC

ELEMENTAL PHIALS - INCOMPLETE?

THUNDER GAUNTLETS (v1-v4)

MAGIC BOOTS?? (NOT SURE WHAT THESE DO)

PHANTOM FLASKS (PURE POISON? DO NOT DRINK)

LOVE POTIONS (ONLY WORK ON RATS)

UNBREAKABLE SILVERWARE (WORDSMITHIUM TYPE 3)

* * *

The stuff on display made Timothy's head spin. He grabbed the magic boots and put them on, but nothing seemed to happen. If they *were* magical, he had no idea what function they had.

He swirled the magical phials around, frowning at the gross-looking liquid inside. What was his father thinking when he made these? What did they even do?

Timothy grabbed the Thunder Gauntlets. He finally saw potential, because they were clearly highly advanced pieces of technology fused with magic. These must have been made by his father near the end of his life, because they were much more sophisticated than the other comparatively sloppy works Timothy had observed so far, and there were multiple prototypes. Clearly, Jason had a coherent idea in mind when he made them.

"Lorent, do you know what these Thunder Gauntlets are?" Timothy asked.

Lorent nearly jumped out of his skin. He quickly ran over, grabbed the box, and hurriedly put it on the shelf. "Careful, kid! Those are not toys. They're weapons of war! If you put one of those on and punch at someone, it'll release a devastating sound-blast that can rupture eardrums and internal organs! It's literally like getting hit by a thunderclap, hence the name. Watch yourself."

Timothy nodded. "Sounds impressive."

"Yeah, I saw your dad test them out a couple of times." Lorent said, rubbing his forehead in relief that Timothy hadn't accidentally killed himself. "Just be careful when you poke around this stuff. Your dad was trying to create weapons to help him win an intergalactic war. Lord only knows what crazy nonsense he whipped up."

[I have located the Queen Network Transmitter.] Ferral suddenly said. [Correction: Miss Shana has located it. I am merely stating that it has been located. I did not intend to misrepresent the truth with a falsified statement. I apologize for my reprehensible behavior.]

Timothy and Lorent walked over to Shana and Ferral. They found Shana staring intently at a large silver helmet held in her tiny hands. She turned it around, looking at it from all different angles. It resembled an ancient Roman Centurion helmet, with a curved chin protector that wrapped around the lower face. Only the direct center of the face wasn't covered by it, and even then, there were green goggles that flipped down over the eyes.

"It's a neural connector." Shana said, holding the helmet up to Timothy. "I can't fix it. Sorry."

Timothy smiled at his aunt. She looked like a child, but mentally she felt like she was about his own age, maybe a few years older.

"Thanks, auntie. I'll see if there's anything I can do."

Timothy reached out. As he took the helmet from Shana's hands, a spike of energy flowed through her body, into the helmet, and into Timothy's hands.

Neither one noticed what had just happened, nor did Ferral or Lorent.

"Let's see..." Timothy said, as he walked over to a workbench and set the helmet down. "The circuitry isn't degraded. What's this piece do here? Oh, I wonder if my dad has any files on the helmet's schematics..."

He booted up the computer inside the museum, which unfortunately took a few minutes. It hadn't been turned on in two decades, and it felt somewhat sluggish.

Timothy spent thirty minutes browsing different files. Eventually, he found exactly what he was looking for; a schematics page detailing how the helmet functioned and how it was constructed.

Ferral hovered over Timothy's shoulder, but Shana and Lorent lingered a little further away.

"Hey kid, me and Shana are gonna go do some painting." Lorent said. "We'll be back in a few hours. Hope you can get that thing working!"

"Yeah, me too." Timothy said absentmindedly. "Bye Lorent, goodbye Shana."

His spiritual aunt and uncle left the warehouse, but Timothy and Ferral stayed behind, poring over the schematics.

Hours passed.

At some point, Timothy had pulled out lots of tools his father had left in boxes on the main desk. They were intended for creating new artifacts and repairing existing ones. With the helmet's schematics available to him, Timothy was able to pull it apart, locate a few internal components that were temporally out of sync, then adjust them to the required sensitivity.

Before long, he had put the helmet back together. He looked at Ferral with eager eyes.

"It's done! Now, we just have to test it."

Ferral nodded, but his expression turned serious. [This object is potentially dangerous. It would not be good if something happened and it destroyed your brain. I should test it first to ensure it will not cause you harm.]

Timothy frowned. "But then if something does go wrong, you'll be the one injured... or worse."

[My existence is of no concern.] Ferral said emotionlessly. [I am an ordinary Psion with below-average prospects. You are the child of humanity's last Trueborn. Your existence is more consequential than mine.]

Timothy's eyes wavered. He looked at Ferral, feeling both deeply touched, and more than a little hurt. He never asked to be the son of a Hero, and Timothy felt that Ferral innately had more potential than he did. But he didn't know how to verbalize those thoughts, so he simply stayed quiet.

"...Alright. You can test it first, then. Just be careful."

He handed the helmet to Ferral, who casually placed it on his head, sat in a chair, and closed his eyes.

A minute passed. Ferral's eyes twitched a few times. Then he opened them.

[I was unable to activate the device. Perhaps it is incompatible with my Psion cerebral biology.]

"That shouldn't be the case. The device is designed to work with all sentient and most non-sentient minds." Timothy said. "Here, let me try."

Ferral stood up, then pulled the helmet off and handed it to Timothy. The young man sat in the chair this time, put the helmet on, then tapped the side of it with his finger.

At once, his vision turned black. Timothy sagged back in the chair, and his consciousness was taken... somewhere else.

* * *

Timothy awoke inside a black void. He found himself standing on a strange island floating in the darkness. It seemed like he was in outer space, but there were no stars present.

The island was little more than a flat stone platform. It extended a hundred feet in any direction, then its edge dropped off into the black abyss.

Timothy looked around and inhaled deeply. The game's simulation was incredible! It was way beyond what he was expecting. He could smell the musty air around him, hear a faint droning sound of some sort that he couldn't properly identify...

At that moment, a large floating textbox appeared in front of Timothy's body. Its words made him scrunch his face together.

[WELCOME TO THE KING NETWORK.]

[YOU HAVE ACTIVATED **PLAYER** PRIVILEGES.]

[WOULD YOU LIKE TO ENABLE THE TUTORIAL COMPANION?]

[YES | NO]

Timothy blinked. Then he blinked again and rubbed his eyes.

"Weird. I thought this was called the Queen Network. I don't know what I was expecting, but it wasn't... this."

He hesitated. Something felt a little off about the situation. Without another word, he looked to his right, where a pop-up HUD of options were hovering just at the edge of his vision.

Without hesitation, Timothy selected the 'log out' option. The void vanished. His vision darkened, then it brightened.

He opened his eyes to see Ferral standing next to him, looking down from above.

[Did the device function for you?] Ferral asked.

Timothy nodded. He sat up and pulled off the helmet, still looking at Ferral.

"Yeah. It was weird though, I arrived in this weird void area, and the game said I had entered the King Network. But you said it was called the Queen Network, right? So why is would it use that name?"

[I do not know.] Ferral answered honestly. [The schematics also stated it was called the Queen Network. Perhaps your father was developing a variant system, and this device connects to it?]

"Yeah." Timothy said, lowering his eyes. "That might be... HUH?"

Timothy blinked yet again.

The same tutorial textbox was floating in front of him.

[WELCOME TO THE KING NETWORK.]

[YOU HAVE ACTIVATED **PLAYER** PRIVILEGES.]

[WOULD YOU LIKE TO ENABLE THE TUTORIAL COMPANION?]

[YES | NO]

Only, this time, he was back in the real world. Not the game world.

"What… what the *hell…?*" Timothy whispered.

Part 679: My Dad Was a Hero and My Mom Was A Great Inventor But Then They Died And Left Me Alone And I Thought I Was Normal But Then I Obtained the Legendary Gaming Power So Now I Can Level Up And Save The Universe From The Demons And Aliens And Plaguehosts Or Eventually Die Trying!!

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

[WELCOME TO THE KING NETWORK.]

[YOU HAVE ACTIVATED **PLAYER** PRIVILEGES.]

[WOULD YOU LIKE TO ENABLE THE TUTORIAL COMPANION?]

[YES | NO]

Timothy stared in shock at the words floating just a few feet in front of his waist, aimed up at his face. He hadn't seen them because he was looking up at Ferral after he took off the helmet, but they were unmissable now.

[Is something the matter?] Ferral asked. [You appear to be in mild distress.]

"That's putting it lightly!" Timothy exclaimed. He pointed in front of himself. "Do you see it?"

Ferral followed Timothy's finger. He blinked.

[I am afraid that unless you speak in more specific terms, I will disappoint you.]

"There's a floating textbox." Timothy said, before reading it out to him. "It looks exactly like what I saw inside the King Network."

Ferral's many eyes gazed at Timothy with little emotion. [I contemplate, and I comprehend. You are hallucinating.]

"No way, this can't be a hallucination. I see it clear as day." Timothy said, before looking more intently at the screen. "It wants to know if I am going to enable the tutorial companion."

Ferral seemed unperturbed. [Well, if this phenomena is real, you might as well say yes. If not, then you will simply hallucinate some more. It is not a problem a little medication cannot solve.]

Timothy decided Ferral was right. Wordlessly, he reached out his hand and touched the screen. Yes, his hand came into physical contact with what felt like a glass panel. He was shocked out of his wits that he didn't wave his hand right through it!

The moment he touched the 'YES' option, the window disappeared.

A blob of light materialized in the air just to the right of Timothy's face. He visibly flinched when it appeared.

"What the-?!"

"**Greetings, inferior biological Player.**" The orb of light said in a robotic female voice. "**My designation is Umi. I am the tutorial companion for the King Network. You may ask me any question regarding the King Network. Please do not ask annoying questions. I do not enjoy answering annoying questions.**"

Timothy rubbed his eyes. He looked at the orb of light more intently than ever, but it simply looked like a bright glowing marble floating in the air.

"Come ON Ferral, you can see THAT, right??"

Ferral simply stared at Timothy with slight concern. [I am unable to perceive anything out of the ordinary. What are you hallucinating now?]

"It's a floating orb of Light. Err, *she's* a floating orb of light. Calls herself Umi. She says she can answer any questions I have regarding the King Network."

[I comprehend.] Ferral said succinctly. [If you are truly not hallucinating, then why not ask this 'Umi' questions? Don't mind me. I will simply evaluate your mental state from the side.]

Timothy nodded. He turned his attention to the floating orb of light.

"Uh... Umi? What... what are you, exactly? What is the King Network? What's even going on?"

Umi's orb slightly pulsed with light. "**You have asked three questions. I will provide three answers. I am Umi, the Unified Management Interface. The King Network was developed by the Creator. Its purpose is to create Kings. As for 'what is going on', you have awakened your Heroic Power. You are the first Player in the King Network.**"

Timothy nodded. He relayed what Umi said to Ferral, then proceeded with his next set of questions.

"Why can't my friend Ferral see you?"

"**Ferral is not a Player. Only Players can interact with the King Network's elements.**"

"Can Ferral become a player?"

"**Affirmative. Any Sentient can become a Player. As the First Player, you are the Administrator and solely possess the ability to add additional Players to the King Network. However, caution is advised. The King Network is extremely powerful, and easily abused. You must only add Players who are trustworthy. Once added, a Sentient can no longer have their Player access removed unless their body and soul permanently expires.**"

Timothy slowly nodded. He gave Ferral a long look before carefully telling him everything Umi had said.

[Most interesting. Your Heroic ability is extremely unique.] Ferral said. [I have never heard of such an ability in all my years alive. Are you going to give me Player access?]

Timothy hesitated. Ferral was his best friend, but once given, the access could not be revoked.

"I... I want to... but I think I need to speak to my mom first. She knows more about this stuff. How about we do it later, once I've gotten a better grasp on the rules?"

Ferral didn't take offense. [Of course. It is your ability. You deserve to take some time to learn how it works. I apologize for being presumptuous. I did not mean to force you into an immediate decision.]

Timothy suddenly felt extremely guilty. Here he was, feeling greedy over hoarding this new power for himself. Why would he deny his best friend, who had been there emotionally for him since his childhood, the opportunity to also be a Player?

But still, pragmatism won out. He decided not to rush into it, praying he hadn't hurt Ferral's feelings. The Psion might often seem emotionless, but Timothy knew he secretly had a deep yearning for fun, adventure, and exploration. He was not as alien and lifeless as the other Psions, and frequently had emotional outbursts that were quite intense. He simply struggled with acting like a 'proper Psion' much of the time.

Timothy swallowed, then turn to Umi.

"What can I do with the King Network?"

"**Your query is too broad. Please narrow down the question to a more specific topic.**" Umi replied.

Timothy scratched his chin. "Um, the King Network... it's like a real life video game, right?"

"**Affirmative. That is a simple and primitive way a low-intellect biological like yourself might refer to it.**" Umi replied. "**A more proper term would be 'Game-like Mechanics Made Manifest through Realistic Virtualization.'**"

Timothy stared at her blankly. "That's... basically the same thing I just said."

"**Incorrect.**" Umi replied.

She did not elaborate any further.

Timothy decided to pause talking to her for a moment. He looked around, then spotted a menu off to the side, with several selectable choices.

INVENTORY

CHARACTER

ABILITIES

PARTY (Locked: Complete Tutorial)

TALENT TREE (Locked: Level 5)

PROFESSION (Locked: ???)

SHOP (Locked: Level 10)

PRESTIGE (Locked: Level 50)

CHEATS (Locked: Level 100)

QUESTS

ACHIEVEMENTS (Locked: Complete Tutorial)

MAP

FAST TRAVEL

SLEEP

OPTIONS

Timothy stared at all the options for a good thirty seconds. After a moment, he hesitantly tapped the Character option. A page on himself materialized in the air, complete with a picture of his face smiling in the top left corner. He looked way more handsome in reality, so clearly the system was taking artistic liberties.

Timothy Hiro - Human/Chrona

Level 0 - Newbie | Bottom Mortal

HP 100/100

AP 0/0 | MP 0/0

STR 10 | DEX 10

INT 10 | WIS 10

DEF 10 | RES 10

CHA 10 | LUK 10

Resistances: None.

Weaknesses: None.

Active Skills: Eye of Yredelemnul, Player's Fixation

Passive Skills: Player's Body, Player's Mind (Toggle)

Talent Slots: 0/1

Prestige: N/A

Timothy stared at the numbers and words for a good long time. After a while, he fixated on one thing in particular.

"What the actual fuck is *Eye of Yredelemnul*? That sounds ominous as shit."

Umi beeped. "**To access information on any given skill, you may tap its name or icon on your character sheet, or you may think of activating it with your mind.**"

Timothy nodded. That made sense. He reached out and touched the skill's name. Its description popped up in his mind.

Eye of Yredelemnul: [MP Cost 0] [AP Cost 0] [Cooldown 0]

The stolen power of a dark god courses through the Player. The Player can examine objects and entities with the Eye of Yredelemnul to learn more information about them. As the Player strengthens, the information available to them will improve drastically.

The explanation only served to make Timothy's heart skip a beat. Why would he want to use the stolen power of some dark god? It sounded horrifying!

But he was... curious.

He turned to look at Ferral, then silently activated the ability with his mind.

Eye of Yredelemnul: Activate.

Immediately, a statsheet for Ferral appeared.

Learner Ferral - Psion/Chrona/Volgrim

Low Mortal

Stats: ???

It told him almost nothing. He only learned Ferral's name and little more than that.

"Umi, why can't I see any of Ferral's stats and other details?" Timothy asked out loud. Ferral looked at him with interest.

"**The Sentient known as 'Ferral' is not a Player. You can only see detailed information on other living and non-living entities once your Player Level has risen, or if those entities become Players.**"

"So if I make Ferral a Player, I'll be able to see his stats?" Timothy asked.

"**Affirmative, and Ferral will be able to see yours. Note that you are currently the exclusive user of the Eye of Yredelemnul skill. But if other Sentients become Players, they may be able to obtain the skill through their own efforts.**"

Timothy's heart skipped a beat. This was good information to know! It meant that if he casually invited people to use the King Network, they would potentially be able to obtain the skills he possessed, thus further ruining his uniqueness.

"Are all skills possible to obtain through the King Network?"

"**Negative. Some skills are classified as Unique. Unique skills can only be obtained by one Player at a time. Thus, if you invite other Sentients to become Players and they obtain those Unique skills, you will never be able to acquire them unless those Players permanently die and their Unique skills become obtainable once again. Unique skills are rare and extremely difficult to obtain. Amassing a collection of them is pivotal to becoming the most powerful Player in the King Network.**"

Timothy scratched his head. He had barely even acquired this power, and already it was starting to feel like a burden. But he was still ecstatic. He finally had a power, just like his father, and it seemed like it had tons of unique utility as well!

He tapped the Inventory tab. It opened up a blank box in midair that was filled with tons of smaller boxes. At present, the Inventory was completely empty.

"How does the Inventory work, Umi?"

"**Your Inventory is composed of Slots. Objects and items you wish to place inside the Inventory will require a larger or greater number of slots based on the object's size. Leveling up, selecting certain skills, and acquiring bonus rewards can all increase the room inside your inventory.**"

"Oh... so it's a slot based system, like Diablo or Deus Ex..." Timothy muttered to himself. The Inventory showed there were ten slots available horizontally and five vertically. He glanced around the room and randomly walked over to pick up a crowbar. He stuffed it into the inventory by directly placing it inside, and 3 of the 50 slots became full.

"It's not exactly a lot, but the item becomes completely weightless. Umi, can I put living things in my Inventory?"

"**Affirmative. However, as there is a vacuum inside the Inventory, any living object placed inside will rapidly lose consciousness and asphyxiate, unless they are immortal and do not require air. Living entities become frozen and unable to move, but can still perceive the world around them. This is considered a form of psychological torture and is generally not recommended. Additionally, living entities are subject to the same size restrictions as other items, thus large entities are unlikely to fit inside the Inventory.**"

Timothy nodded seriously. "Right. I just won't bother then."

He decided to experiment with his abilities a little. Timothy walked over to various shelves and picked up random artifacts and items his dad had made. Suddenly, a thought came to his mind. He picked up one of the random vials of brown liquid.

Eye of Yredelemnul: Activate.

Information appeared in his mind.

Consumable: Murky Brown Liquid.

Effect: Unknown

Uses: 1/1

The information given to him was... unhelpful.

"Why is this eye so useless?" Timothy complained.

"**The Eye of Yredelemnul is an extremely powerful ability that can only utilize its full power when a Player is of sufficient level to properly wield it.**

Your level is insufficient, so the information it can reveal is generally meaningless." Umi replied.

"Right..." Timothy grunted. He picked up a few other items, but their descriptions were not very useful either. He ended up shoving them into his Inventory to see how much stuff he could fit inside. Generally, he was quite pleased with what he found.

It turned out the weight of items was much less important than the size. An extremely dense tungsten bar took up less space than a long and skinny plastic bat. This meant he could store more items if he picked small and dense ones. Maybe if he found a way to shrink larger items down or fold them into smaller shapes...

Timothy glanced at the plastic bat. He pulled it out of the inventory and handed it to Ferral, who had quietly watched Timothy going about testing his powers from the side.

"Hey, Ferral. Could you use your telekinesis to fold this bat in half for me? Try not to break it."

Ferral nodded. With little effort, he bent the bat in half and turned it into a tightly squished U-shaped version of itself. When Timothy tried to put it in his inventory, he was shocked to see that it hadn't gone from 3 squares of storage required to 2, but instead to just 1!

"Whoa! So making stuff smaller would actually do a lot! Good to know." Timothy muttered.

Ferral continued to watch. By now, he had stopped doubting his eyes. The fact Timothy was able to place items into and retrieve them from some sort of imperceptible storage dimension indicated he wasn't hallucinating. He really had acquired a Heroic power!

After learning the basic limits of his inventory, Timothy pulled everything back out and placed the items in their original locations. He flicked through the Menu again and selected the Quests tab.

Starter Quest: [Complete Tutorial]

Continue speaking to Umi until all questions have been resolved. You may end the Tutorial at any time and gain access to locked abilities and other tabs whenever you please. You may also re-enable the Tutorial as desired in case additional assistance is required.

Timothy made a strange expression. He didn't realize he could simply end the tutorial and start wielding his full powers at will. But he still felt he had a lot of questions, and there was no need to rush into things.

He returned to the Character Menu and looked at his information carefully.

With a single thought, he called up the information for his second Active Skill.

Player's Fixation: [Unique] [MP Cost 0] [AP Cost 0] [Cooldown 24 Hours]

The Player can focus their mind for an extended period of time, increasing learning rate and speed for a specific task by up to 500%, depending on the Player's emotional investment and mental interest in the task. High investment and interest will result in a higher payoff. Lower values will thus lead to a lower return. The player will be locked in this state for up to twelve hours or until the task is finished, whichever is the lesser time value. The Player will need to fully sleep back to maximum mental focus and then wait 24 hours before this skill can be activated again.

Timothy's eyes widened. "Oh shit, that's actually super useful. Whoa!"

Then he looked up the other skills.

Player's Body: [Passive] [Global]

The Player's body no longer follows the rule of ordinary living entities. Damage inflicted will be spread across the entire body, reducing the Player's HP accordingly. Attacks landing on weak points of the Player's body, such as the head or groin, will inflict bonus damage. The player will still feel localized pain in any areas struck. When below certain HP thresholds, the Player will suffer from additional ailments, such as [Lightly Wounded], [Injured], [Maimed], and [Broken]. The Player can recover one injury state by sleeping for at least eight hours, but extreme injuries will require multiple Well Rested buffs to counteract.

Player's Mind (Toggle): [Passive] [Global] [Cooldown 24 Hours]

The Player is able to toggle between various mental states at will, which will enter cooldown after swapping mental states. Mental states offer different positive and negative effects that will vary depending on which states the Player has acquired. More states can be acquired from various sources, including leveling up and quest rewards.

Current mental states available:

Mind of Simplicity: [CURRENTLY SELECTED] 20% resistance to negative mental ailments, such as Fear and Anxiety. No personality changes.

Mind of Focus: Thinking speed decreased by 50%. Mental focus increased 200%. CHA reduced by 50%. INT and WIS increased by 50%. Personality altered to RESEARCHER.

Mind of Void: Immunity to telepathic intrusion. Telepathic attacks reflected back at attacker at 100% damage. Distracting thoughts can be silenced for thirty minute intervals at the cost of 1 MP/Min. Personality altered to PSIOPHOBIC.

The more Timothy looked at these skills, the more amazed he became. He had somehow broken the laws of reality and become a living video game player!

Without hesitation, he grabbed a random cutting tool off the table. Ferral's body jerked in alarm when he saw Timothy slap his left hand on the workbench, then take the cutting tool with his right hand and carefully pull it across his arm.

"OUCH! Shit, that hurts!" Timothy yelped, quickly stopping what he was doing. He gazed at the wound with bright eyes and saw that he hadn't bled at all. His arm hurt like a motherfucker though. It genuinely felt like someone had cut him.

A glance at his HP revealed that he had gone from 100 HP to 96.

[Timothy? Have you gone mad? Why did you attack yourself?] Ferral asked with deep concern. It did not escape his notice that despite Timothy's scream of pain, the young man had not seriously injured himself. He wasn't even bleeding!

Timothy held his arm, wincing at the very real pain he was experiencing. Unfortunately, it seemed his health was not regenerating, or if it was, it was at an extremely slow speed he couldn't perceive. At least he could probably heal the damage when he went to sleep later.

"My god, Ferral. This power is insane!" Timothy said, half grinning and half scared of what he had become. In one instant, he had transformed from an ordinary human into a Hero. That meant he couldn't just sit around, goofing off all day. He had work to do!

[Can you tell me about what you've learned?] Ferral asked. [I will not pry if you do not wish to say.]

"No, no. It's cool, man. You're my best friend, Ferral. I'll tell you everything. Maybe even more than I tell my own mom."

And so he did. Timothy spent the better part of ten minutes telling Ferral every little discovery he'd made, what all his skills did, everything he could think of.

Ferral listened without judgment. His eyes lit up sometimes. He became more and more excited by what he'd heard.

[Timothy. Your power is... it is enviable. I am ashamed to admit that I am feeling great desire at using it myself.] Ferral said, wringing his hands together. [I would very much like to experience the joy of being a Player. I cannot, and will not force you. But I would be extremely appreciative if you were to extend me the privilege.]

Timothy's smile vanished. He stared at Ferral with deep emotions. He wasn't sure why he was so hesitant to extend the power to Ferral. Maybe it was because he had finally, for the first time in his life, acquired something that made him feel like he deserved to be his father's son. Maybe it was because he didn't want to just give away that which made him special after he'd barely even gotten to play around with his power.

Timothy chewed his lower lip and looked away.

[I see that you are still hesitant.] Ferral said, lowering his eyes. [I apologize. Never mind my request. I am being selfish in asking for your Uniqueness.]

"No. You're not being selfish. I am." Timothy muttered. He turned to Umi. "Umi, are there any restrictions on who can enter the King Network?"

"**Affirmative.**" Umi replied. "**As a Newbie, you can only invite three other people into your direct Party. All Party members must share experience acquired unless they are a great distance from each other. Later on, as the Administrator has reached various satisfactory level requirements, the limits on Player Count will gradually rise.**"

"Oh, so it's like that." Timothy said. He looked at Ferral thoughtfully.

After thinking for a while, he nodded.

"Alright Ferral. I can only invite three people to become Players. You're my best friend, so I'm obviously giving you a slot. I don't know who the other two should be, though.

Maybe my mom? Uncle Lorent? Shana? Blinker and Kar? Rebecca? Lots of options..."

[You are truly going to let me become a Player too?] Ferral asked, becoming visibly elated. [Thank you, Timothy! I know you are extending a great trust my way. I will not betray that trust!]

Timothy smiled. He spoke to Umi a bit more, then deactivated the Tutorial temporarily in order to enable the Party tab. After that, he took a look at Ferral, then sent him a friend request.

Ferral nearly jumped out of his skin. The young Psion telepathically gasped when a game window appeared in front of him.

[AN ADMINISTRATOR IS INVITING YOU TO THE KING NETWORK.]

[IF YOU ACCEPT THIS REQUEST, YOU WILL BECOME A **PLAYER**.]

[WILL YOU ACCEPT THE FRIEND REQUEST AND JOIN TIMOTHY HIRO'S PARTY?]

[YES | NO]

Ferral's body shook with excitement. He didn't hesitate before jabbing his finger against the [YES] prompt.

In that moment, a whole new world opened for him, and the two friends embarked on the next major chapter of their lives together.

Part 680: The Power of Friendship

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

The moment Timothy decided to pass on the power of the Player to Ferral, it changed both their lives forever. Ferral eagerly pressed the YES option, and his body changed irreversibly.

Becoming a Player was absolutely a power-up. But it had some minor downsides. The System was now an ever-present part of their lives, and they had no idea the influence it would have on their behavior.

After Ferral became a Player, he fell completely silent for five entire minutes. Timothy stared at him, but Ferral simply didn't say anything.

After a short while, Timothy tapped on the PARTY option. He was able to bring up Ferral's Character information without needing to use the Eye of Yredelemnul.

Learner Ferral - Psion/Chrona/Volgrim

Level 0 - Learner | Low Mortal

HP 514/514

AP 14/14 | PP 76/76

STR 20 | DEX 20

INT 20 | WIS 20

DEF 20 | RES 20

CHA 20 | LUK 20

Resistances: Piercing: 45%. Blunt: 32%. Asphyxiation: 100%. Elemental: 22%. Telepathy: 45%.

Weaknesses: Magic: 21%.

Active Skills: Psionic Slam, Psionic Pull, Psionic Telepathy (14 Others)

Passive Skills: Player's Body, Player's Mind (Toggle), Psionic Flight, Multiclass Lifeform

Talent Slots: 0/1

Prestige: N/A

Timothy's eyes damn near fell out of his head. Ferral was level 0 just like Timothy, but his stats were way higher! And not just a little bit higher, but insanely higher. His stats were double Timothy's, he had PP instead of MP, and he had a base 14 AP as well. To top it all off, he had so many Psionic abilities that they didn't even fit on the page! And what were all those resistances??

The more Timothy looked, the more jealous he felt. That jealousy turned to shame, shame which he was forced to rationalize.

Of course Ferral is way stronger than me. He's thousands of years old! He's been practicing his Psionics for a long time. He's already on par with a Demon Lord, right? And I'm essentially just an ordinary human with a tiny new gimmick...

Before Timothy could say anything he might regret, Ferral spoke first.

[Timothy. I have spent the last few minutes examining my Character sheet. Have you looked at it yet?]

Timothy nodded slowly. He tried not to sound resentful. "Y-yeah. Impressive stats. And you're the same level as me, even."

[The same level, yes. I noticed that as well. But have you noticed my final passive skill?]

Timothy looked at Ferral's sheet again. *Multiclass Lifeform*.

"I see it. The System isn't letting me see what it does, though. Umi, why can't I read what Ferral's skills do?"

Umi beeped. "**The King Network innately blocks any attempts to read detailed information on other people. Using the Eye of Yredelemnul will allow you to bypass this restriction, but only once you reach a higher level. For now, you are limited to the basic information on your party member's sheet, as well as the information they tell you.**"

Timothy nodded slowly. If his Eye of Yredelemnul didn't get stronger, he would have about the same information regarding Ferral's abilities as Ferral did his. At least Timothy

had a built-in way of bypassing this limit. Ferral, it seemed, currently did not.

Timothy relayed Umi's words to Ferral. It seemed the two of them could communicate with Umi, but only their own 'instance' of her. If Umi spoke to Timothy, Ferral couldn't hear what she was saying, and vice-versa.

[I see. Well, the skill 'Multiclass Lifeform' is not a good skill. It is actually quite bad for me. The description reads: *You were an enhanced life-form with your own evolution system before you joined the King Network. As such, Experience rewards will be reduced by 67%, loot drop quantity and quality will be reduced by 79%, and currency gain will be reduced by 86%. New skills you acquire must relate to your existing class. You are unable to acquire skills that your species is incompatible with.*]

Timothy felt his heart lighten. That in turn made him feel guilty. Here he was, feeling elated that his closest friend had obtained a shittier version of the game system. What kind of friend did that make Timothy?

He swallowed heavily. "I'm sorry to hear that, Ferral. It seems, because you're already an enhanced Psion, and not an ordinary sentient like me, the system has balanced itself around what powers you already possess."

Ferral looked glum for a moment, but then his eyes brightened up. [It is fine. In the end, I now get to experience life like a game! This is a most pleasurable turn of events. Perhaps it will still lead to a large spike in my personal power.]

He looked at Timothy, then he frowned in the way only a Psion with many eyes could.

[Strange. Your stats are not what you said they were when we spoke earlier.]

"They're not??" Timothy asked. He pulled up his Character page and nearly jumped out of his skin!

Timothy Hiro - Human/Chrona

Level 0 - Newbie | Bottom Mortal

HP 100/100

AP 0/0 | MP 0/0

STR 1 | DEX 1

INT 1 | WIS 1

DEF 1 | RES 1

CHA 1 | LUK 1

Resistances: None.

Weaknesses: None.

Active Skills: Eye of Yredelemnul, Player's Fixation

Passive Skills: Player's Body, Player's Mind (Toggle)

Talent Slots: 0/1

Prestige: N/A

His eyes widened. He felt as if the breath had been sucked out of his body.

"Umi! UMI! What the hell is going on? Why did all my stats drop from 10 to 1?! Why is Ferral at 20? Can you please explain??"

Umi beeped. "**The King Network does not display character stats in the way you might expect. Instead, all stats are relative to what each player has personally observed. A value of 10 is the baseline average or median value. When a Player observes life forms stronger or weaker than them than them, the Player's stats will change, as well as the stats of the life-forms they have observed. A stat of 1 is the minimum possible value. A stat of 20 is the highest possible value. Since you have only observed your stats and Ferral's stats, and since all of Ferral's parameters are much higher than yours, your stats have been adjusted to reflect this new information.**"

Timothy gawked at the tiny orb of light. He almost felt his soul crumble to ashes.

"I don't... I don't understand. Relative stat values? What does that even mean?"

"**If you observe the status of an entity stronger than Ferral, Ferral's stats will drop.**" Umi replied. "**If you observe entities weaker than yourself, your stats will increase, and Ferral's may lower. Simply put: The King Network needs data on many different types of Sentients and non-sentients alike in order to assess the strength levels of the universe. Until you have observed a large number of other creatures, you should not value your stats too highly.**"

Timothy felt his body temperature cool down a bit. It all made sense now. Since Ferral was innately a far stronger life form than him, Ferral's stats were represented as being all maxed out, while Timothy was maxed out in the opposite direction. If he looked up the stats of a random cat or dog, he'd add more data for the system to adjust every other entity's stats in the future.

"But I can't observe the stats of other entities until my Eye of Yredelemnul becomes stronger." Timothy pointed out.

"**Correct. And to improve the Eye of Yredelemnul, you must improve your Player Level. Right now, that should be your foremost goal.**"

Timothy nodded. He definitely wanted to start leveling up. Once he did, he'd get new skills, abilities, and other fun stuff. He'd grow stronger, and that would pay off in dividends over the long run.

Timothy glanced at his sheet and Ferral's once again. He scratched his cheek with a fingernail thoughtfully.

"Umi, why am I a 'Bottom Mortal' while Ferral is a 'Low Mortal'? What's the difference?"

"**Just as there are multiple classifications for Cosmics, there are classifications for Mortals as well.**" Umi answered.

"**Whelps are Sentients that essentially cannot protect themselves, such as human children and demon imps.**"

"**Bottom Mortals consist of ordinary humans, Demon Grunts, and 1st Level Psions.**"

"**Low Mortals consist of Lowborn Heroes, Demon Lords, and 2nd Level Psions.**"

"**Mortals consist of Lowborn Heroes, Demon Barons, and 3rd Level Psions.**"

"**Middle Mortals consist of Trueborn Heroes, Demon Dukes, and 4th Level Psions.**"

"**High Mortals consist of Trueborn Heroes, Demon Emperors, and 5th Level Psions.**"

"**Apex Mortals consist of Hero Kings, Demon Overlords, and 6th Level Psions.**"

"**And finally, Cosmics consist of Bottom, Low, Middle, High, and Apex Cosmics.**"

Timothy held up his hand.

"Wait, wait, wait. There's six classifications for mortals, plus an extra for kids and imps?? I already know about the classifications for Cosmics. Why would there be five for Cosmics but seven for mortals? Why do Mortals just have 'Mortals' while also having Middle Mortals? Who even came up with these classifications?"

If Umi could shrug, she would definitely have done so. "**The Creator was originally a stupid and foolish inferior biological, after all. It is only natural that he would make careless mistakes like this. But you are incorrect in one regard. Rulers are considered the final evolution of Cosmics, thus there are six forms of Cosmics, and six forms of Mortals; Whelps do not count as combatants. There can only be one Ruler per galaxy, but that is beside the point.**"

"Right. Well, I guess whoever came up with the rankings didn't initially put enough thought into it." Timothy mused. "Anyway, since Ferral is a 2nd Level Psion, that puts him on par with a Demon Lord? And thus he's a Low Mortal? Makes sense. But what's this about Demon Overlords? I've never heard of them before."

"**The sixth level of mortal power is not one demons can naturally achieve, as their entire base of power comes from Soul Manipulation, which inherently goes against the fabric of Akasha's universe.**" Umi patiently explained. "**Nevertheless, there have been a small number of Demon Overlords throughout history. They were simply unaware of their lauded status, or unwilling to speak of it. Beelzebub, of this era, is one such Overlord.**"

"Oh, Beelzebub is?" Timothy muttered. "He's that flame guy, right? I've seen him on the Spynet a few times. Interesting."

Timothy didn't have any relationship with Beelzebub. For all Jason's son knew, Beelzebub was just one of a sea of faceless demons he barely recognized. Timothy was better acquainted with the faces of female demons. Particularly the *attractive* ones.

* * *

Now that Timothy had resolved his doubts about his sudden 'drop' in stats, he felt a lot better. He started poking around the other options in the King Network.

Since he had technically completed the tutorial prematurely, only to then re-enable it, he opted to skip the stuff that was still supposed to be hidden. His eyes moved down to two options...

"Map and Fast Travel? Umi, how do these work?"

He tapped on the Map option. Immediately, a zoomed-out 3D map of the nearby region of Chrona appeared. It showed two dots of green light, and when Timothy looked at them, they showed his name and Ferral's.

"**The MAP function allows Players to see the local area around them.**" Umi explained. "**Right now, you have only just acquired the King Network, and thus your map contains little information and functionality. Additional skills you acquire later on, specific professions, and further examination of the region will expand your map's functionality. You can ping other Party members regarding specific map locations, and you can add information visible to yourself and others about those locations.**"

She continued. "**Fast Travel allows you to designate Beacons and then return to them later. Note that there is a 168 hour cooldown between fast travel jumps.**"

"Beacons? That's... that's similar to how my father traveled around the galaxy." Timothy said, remembering stories his mother had told him about Jason's magic.

"**Beacons must be constructed using specific resources. At present, you have only just begun the Game, and thus possess no such resources.**" Umi said blandly. "**As an inferior biological, I imagine it will take you quite some time to acquire those resources. However, if you can find prebuilt Beacons, you can travel to them later.**"

"Prebuilt ones? Are you talking about the ones my father made?" Timothy asked.

Umi remained silent. Her orb floated in the air, seemingly mocking him for asking such an idiotic question.

Timothy lowered his eyes. He thought carefully about her words.

After pondering the matter, he decided that he would move on and focus on new information.

He looked at the SLEEP option. Umi told him it would allow him to sleep for set periods any time he wished. This would allow him to recover from serious bodily injuries at will, though the quality of his sleep would be affected based on mental exhaustion and the pain he was enduring.

Finally, there was the Options Menu.

Timothy opened it up. He was completely flabbergasted by what he saw.

"...Visual options? Audio? Hold on, why are there *Keybindings*? Gameplay settings... CREDITS?? But there's only two names in the credits! What even is this menu??"

Timothy squinted. He scrolled through the visual options first.

"I can change the resolution. Of what, *reality*? Uh, alright. It's set to 100k now. What if I lower it to 50k?"

He did. The world around him shimmered. Not much seemed to change. He felt as though maybe things were the tiniest bit blurrier, but he couldn't be sure.

He adjusted to 25k, then 5k, then 4k...

Immediately, the differences became extremely noticeable. The universe itself became more and more 'fake' looking. It started looking like a high fidelity video game, until it stopped even looking like that. By the time he'd made it to 240p, the universe looked so awful he started to feel dizzy.

He finally bumped the quality back up to 100k and shook his head. "Alright. Last time I ever do that."

Then he looked at the FPS settings. Surprisingly, the FPS was set to 60. He adjusted it higher, and higher still...

"120 FPS... 144... 256... 512... I don't see a difference."

"**That is because the human eye cannot perceive any difference beyond 60 Frames Per Second.**" Umi helpfully intoned. "**A likely result of your inferior biology.**"

Timothy shrugged, then reduced the speed down to 144 FPS. He didn't know why, but things did seem a *little* bit smoother, but he couldn't be entirely certain. Maybe it was just

a placebo effect.

Timothy found other options. He enabled Motion Blur, which turned out to be horrid. "Who would even add this dogshit of an option? It looks so bad!"

Then he found an option to change the King Network's UI colors. He chose a cool black color with white text and golden borders. "Dark Mode is so much easier on the eyes."

He moved on to the Audio section. He was surprised to see dozens, hundreds, even thousands of highly specific things he could adjust in volume.

"Heartbeat sound? Oh god, turning that up to 300% makes everyone's hearts sound like car engines! Tinnitus volume? Yeah, I'm just gonna set that to 0%. Baby crying sound? Maybe if there's an annoying baby, I guess? Oh hey, there's even a setting for 'nagging mom'! That could come in useful later. Ah, subtitles. Yeah, I'll just enable those. I did sometimes have trouble making out exactly what people were saying."

He moved on. The gameplay options were a lot more interesting.

"Crosshair options... oh, that adds a crosshair dead center of wherever I'm looking. ... ... Okay, I don't like that. Feels weird. Oooh, I can turn on a fitness tracker? Wow, it shows my calorie count and other useful stuff. This will be great for tracking my progress when I hit the gym!"

He found other settings too. "Party notifications... damage numbers... auto-reload... man, there's a lot. I'll revisit this menu later."

With a wave of his hand, Timothy dismissed the Options menu, then looked eagerly at the Talent Tree. When he opened it, he was shocked by what he saw.

"There's... only 6 skills available? I can branch out in any direction, but there's only six options to start, and I can't see anything else. Umi, what gives?"

"**The Talent Tree is an extremely powerful method of Player progression.**" Umi replied dutifully. "**However, all nodes are based on the Player's individual self. Your Talent Tree will be different from every other Player, and it can also change based on the Profession you choose later.**"

"Profession? Like being a Hunter, Warrior, and so on?"

"**Information on Professions is locked until you complete the prerequisite requirements.**" Umi said simply. "**To begin earning experience and leveling up,**

you should check your Quests tab."

Timothy nodded. He had looked at the Quests tab before, but that was back when the only option available was to complete the Tutorial. He opened it again, and this time there were four quests available.

[Story] Talk to Your Mother.

Find your mother, Fiona Hiro, and inform her of your new abilities. Completing this quest will unlock the next quest in the quest chain.

Rewards: [12 EXP], Lootbox Tier 1.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Training With Ferral.

You and Ferral are both Newbies, but Ferral is a stronger Sentient than you. Train your combat skills with him to increase your capabilities.

Rewards: [3 EXP], 3x Lootbox Tier 1.

[Side Quest] Conquer the Volgrim Empire.

The Volgrim Empire is in crisis. Billions of innocents are dying every day to the Plague. Come up with a way to save the Empire and install yourself as its new leader.

Rewards: [860,723,441 EXP], 714x Lootbox Tier 10, 41x Prestige Points, Multiclass Support Added, 3x Unique Skills, (15 Others)

[Side Quest] Pick Flowers.

Your mother has been feeling tired and dragged down recently, and you owe her a real apology. Why not pick some pretty flowers for her to brighten up her day?

Rewards: [0 EXP], Your Mother's Smile.

Timothy stared blankly at these Quests for a while. Obviously, conquering the Volgrim Empire would give him insane rewards, but wasn't it a little ridiculous to even show this quest when he had only just obtained his power? And what was with that silly side-quest about picking flowers for his mom??

Timothy felt bewildered. He looked at Ferral. "Hey, have you completed the Tutorial yet?"

[Naturally,] Ferral replied. [Since it is optional, I skipped it and enabled the Tutorial Companion afterward.]

"Alright, and what Quests do you have available now?" Timothy asked.

[I have not checked. Give me a moment.]

Ferral pulled up his Quest screen, then read them out loud to Timothy. Timothy's face fell.

"Why are your quests so much better than mine? They give good rewards, AND they're simple to achieve!"

[Simple, yes. Easy, *no*. Reaching the 3rd Level of Psionics is no simple matter.] Ferral said. [Defeating my Teacher in a martial battle is likewise going to be extremely difficult if I wish to progress my Story Quests. As for the others, like practicing 1000 Psionic Blasts, those are simply going to require a lot of time for me to complete. Luckily, I am in no rush.]

Ferral's Quests were all related to his proficiency as a Psion. They were pretty much the sorts of things he already would have done even without the System, so they made sense to Timothy. Unfortunately, Timothy's quests were a lot more bizarre and less focused.

"Well..." Timothy said slowly. "We're both Players now. I guess I'm going to get started on my Quests. That means I'll need to go see my mom. You wanna stay here and wait for Lorent and Shana to return? Let them know about everything that's happened?"

Ferral nodded. [Yes, I am going to begin progress on my own quests. It seems that with the King Network, my ability to progress in multiple Psionic Disciplines at once will be greatly enhanced. As such, I am going to begin levitating as many small objects around myself at once as possible to improve my fine control of Primal Psionics.]

Timothy gave his best friend a thumbs up. "Sounds good! I'll be back later."

Timothy turned and left. As he exited the warehouse and started to head toward the Spynet, where his mom was sure to be, he paused.

"I mean, it couldn't *hurt* to grab some flowers for her, could it?"

Timothy glanced off to the west, where the central gardens were. He opted to take a small detour.

"Small gestures matter." Timothy reminded himself.

Part 681: "I'm Not a Fraud!"

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy headed to the Spynet after picking his mom some flowers. He was surprised to see that the Spynet had been locked, which was definitely out of the ordinary. No doubt, Fiona had done so to prevent him from sneaking in and peeping on girls again, but the fact she even felt the need hurt Timothy's feelings. He realized he'd betrayed her trust worse than he expected, and now she was taking noticeably more drastic actions than she'd ever felt the need to do before.

Trust, once lost, was difficult to regain. Timothy knew that much.

He tried to push the door open, but failed. Then, as he was about to knock, he paused.

There were words floating in the air in front of his eyes.

Fiona: I'm just not sure what to do about him. I love him to death, but now he's creeping on girls. Is this normal behavior?

Kar: Hurgh, what male would not enjoy gazing upon the beauty of a voluptuous female? I believe you are blowing this matter up too much.

Blinker: I don't know, Kar has a point, but the way Timothy went about doing it was definitely wrong. Have you punished him yet?

Fiona: No... I was thinking I should, but I don't know what sort of punishment fits the crime... and you know I hate doing stuff like that. It's not like I'm his real mother. I don't want to make him hate me...

Timothy stared at the words that were appearing in front of him. He couldn't hear a thing inside the Spynet, yet apparently he was close enough that he had triggered his new power's Subtitle functionality. He'd played games that did this sort of thing before, but now it made him feel awful. This definitely wasn't a conversation he should be listening in on.

But still... he *was* curious... so he simply stood there, staring dumbly at the words levitating in front of the door.

Blinker: You can't say things like that. You're the only mother Timothy has ever known. I know for a fact he loves you the same as he would have loved Phoebe.

Fiona: But how can he really? I'm not even a real person. I'm just a spiritual copy of a dead woman. I'm not as smart as Phoebe, I can't leave Chrona or I'll die, and I don't even need to sleep. What kind of real human doesn't need sleep? My skin is cold to the touch, I'm not pleasant to hug... I know Timothy probably hates me...

Fiona: [*Crying noises*.]

Blinker: C-come on, Fiona... that's no way to talk about yourself! Besides, you're super smart. You keep Chrona working. Without you, this place would have crumbled a long time ago!

Kar: Butterfly is right. Hurgh! You are being much too hard on yourself. You should be proud if five percent of your brilliance rubs off on Game Boy! I think you need to stop treating yourself so badly and stop seeing things in the worst possible light. So what if he peeped on some females? Just send him to me for a month or two. I'll whip him into shape with hard labor! Maybe I can even show him how to properly romance a woman!

Blinker: Err, Kar, that's a nice thing to offer, but I don't know if your crocodile mating rituals will be very effective for a human boy...

Kar: ABSURD! Butterfly, you know my chuffing noises drive you wild in bed! Once I teach him my Death Roll mating move-!

Blinker: Kar, *please*. Let's be serious here.

* * *

Timothy took a few steps back from the door, too guilty to listen any further. He looked down at the bundle of flowers in his hand, feeling more miserable than ever. He'd come here to make amends to his mother and show off his new powers, but now he felt lower than dirt. He'd made his mother cry, and even made her doubt whether she was a good mother at all.

What kind of son would do that? What kind of man would do what he did? Didn't it just go to show that he was too reclusive, to the point that it made his mom think he didn't love her?

Timothy stared off into the distance, thinking about his seventeen years of life. He couldn't remember his father's face, or his birth mother's face. Not as they were when they were alive. He's seen the mausoleum with their bodies frozen in stasis. He'd seen

their sculptures, and videos of them from years before. But he had no memories of them in person. They died when he was less than a year old.

Fiona was the only mother he knew. How could she think he didn't love her?

The answer was obvious. He never really told her as much. He sat in his room, playing video games, watching movies, and barely interacting with the outside world.

The truth was, he had been depressed. He had felt lifeless, like he was a useless boy growing into a useless man.

Timothy looked at the King Network's UI, which always hovered at the edge of his vision. Obtaining his power had finally made him feel like he had a purpose, but was that really the case? By thinking he couldn't do anything without it, hadn't he also been subtly denigrating his own mother? By implying that powerless people had no value, hadn't he implied that she had no value?

It was no wonder she felt as if he didn't love her. He'd told her so a thousand times, without ever needing to verbalize the words.

"I have to do better..." Timothy said quietly. "It took me receiving powers to realize I never needed powers to be a better person. Even if I had just spent more time with my mom and made her feel loved, that would have made my existence a worthwhile addition to the world. My mom deserves to be loved."

Timothy thought about his father, Jason. From the information he'd gathered over the years, Jason had simply made Fiona as an assistant in his Mind Realm. He'd cloned Phoebe thoughtlessly, treating Fiona like a mere accessory. When push came to shove, Jason treated his 'real' wife like a goddess, but tossed Fiona aside like garbage.

Fiona had already been abandoned by the man she loved. It was no wonder she had attachment issues with Timothy, who wasn't her 'real' son.

"I am her son. She's my mom." Timothy said quietly, steeling his heart. "I can't make her cry ever again. I have to do better!"

Timothy gritted his teeth. He stepped toward the Spynet door, then loudly knocked against it three times.

"Hey, mom? Mom, are you in there?" Timothy asked loudly. "You got a minute to talk?"

Timothy glanced down. He couldn't hear what anyone was saying, but the subtitles reappeared now that he was close enough.

Blinker: Is that Timothy? What good timing. I can't wait to give him an earful for making Fiona cry.

Fiona: No, no, don't do that. It's not his fault. I just- just give me a minute, I need to clean myself up. Don't let him know I was crying, okay? He already feels bad enough.

Kar: Hurgh, I'll go delay him for a minute or two. You two stay here.

Timothy took a step back from the door. He frowned.

After a few seconds, an idea popped into his head. It wouldn't be right for him to let the others know he'd spied on their conversation, especially after the peeping incident. Frankly, he thought of himself even more lowly now, since he'd done the exact same thing again.

He decided he would just have to play stupid.

The door opened and Kar poked his head out. He looked down and spotted Timothy.

"Hurgh! Game Boy, what did you want? White Ghost and Butterfly are having an important conversation."

Kar's body had been mostly healed after all these years in Chrona. He could walk normally, but he still experienced terrible spikes of pain if he attempted to lift heavy objects or bend over. He was glad to be able to move around on his own power, but it seemed he would never be the powerful Monster King he once was.

Timothy blinked his eyes innocently. "Uncle Kar, you're here? Well that's great! I had some really really good news to tell mom. But uh, you mind stepping out here for a second first?"

Kar slowly nodded. He carefully opened the door and slipped through it before closing it behind himself, taking care not to let Timothy see inside. Clearly, he didn't want to risk the boy seeing his mother crying.

Timothy pretended to be oblivious. He held up the bouquet he'd made.

"I realized I haven't been acting right, the last few years. Last night was a real wake-up call for me- oh! Did mom tell you... what she caught me doing?"

Kar crossed his arms and looked at the boy with a grave expression. "Hurgh. That's right. You were peeping upon females of many different types and species."

Yeah..." Timothy said, looking away and rubbing the back of his head sheepishly. "I knew it was wrong, but I kept doing it anyway. When mom caught me, I wanted to crawl in a hole and die."

Kar's expression softened, even if only a little. "Don't be so hard on yourself, Game Boy. Every male makes mistakes. What matters is that you learn from them."

"Yeah, I know." Timothy said. "I realized I've been way too closed off these last few years. I barely leave the house, barely talk to mom, and I'm turning into a lazy degenerate person. I think it's time I made a change."

Kar tilted his head. "Hence the flowers?"

"Yeah!" Timothy chirped. "Mom's been feeling tired lately. I thought maybe some flowers would cheer her up. Doesn't hurt as an apology, either."

Kar lowered his arms to his side and rested a hand on his hip. "Hurgh. That is good. You are learning, Game Boy. What you did was not good, but if you work hard, you can repair the damage you did to you and your mother's relationship. I know for a fact she will not be angry with you for long."

Timothy's heart spiked with pain, but he maintained his same casual smile.

"That's good, Uncle Kar. But, well, there is another reason I came here..."

"Another reason? And what would that be?" Kar asked.

* * *

The door to the Spynet flew open. Kar stormed into the room with a look of excitement on his face.

"Game Boy did it! He really did it! He got his powers!! Hurgh, hurgh, this is great! I am so happy I could just... ROOOAAAARR!!!"

Kar's extreme emotional outburst caught Blinker and Fiona offguard. By this point, Fiona had already dried her eyes and made herself look presentable. When Timothy walked in behind Kar, he couldn't tell his mother had been crying, aside from the slightest puffiness in her eyes. If it was the him of 24 hours ago, he wouldn't have noticed at all.

"What?" Fiona asked, looking at her son with wonder. "Power? Timothy, you unlocked your power?"

Timothy forced a smile. He didn't realize Kar would rush in and blabber the news, so now his flowers would not have the effect he originally intended. Still, he could only dance along with the rhythm of life.

"Yeah, mom. I came here to tell you. Also, I really wanted to bring you some flowers..."

Timothy sheepishly held out his makeshift bouquet. Looking at the selection, he suddenly felt his color choices were extremely shabby. They weren't even held together with anything, and the gesture was so low effort his mom probably wouldn't even-

"You brought me flowers?" Fiona asked, a sparkle of wonder in her eyes. "T-Timothy... you've... you've never brought me flowers before..."

Timothy felt as if he'd taken ten emotional damage. He flinched at his mom's words. "Never? Oh... well I really wanted to tell you I was sorry, so I brought them... I know they're not arranged very well or anything..."

Fiona darted over and took the flowers from him. "Don't even say that. They're beautiful! Oh, Timothy, this is so sweet of you! I could... kiss you! Mwah!"

Fiona excitedly hugged her son and kissed his cheek, making him blush. He quickly hugged her back. "Haha, I'm glad you like them, mom. Sorry about earlier..."

"Oh that's... it's nothing. Just don't do it again, okay?" Fiona said, pulling away. She looked at the flowers again with sparkles in her eyes, making Timothy feel extremely strange.

For such a small gesture to mean so much to her... how badly have I been neglecting my mom?

Timothy spent a few minutes talking to his mom, getting her to calm down, and generally lowering the excitement level of the room. Then, he took a deep breath.

"So... about my power."

"Yes! Your power! What is it?" Kar quickly asked, clearly the person in the room most excited by Timothy's revelation.

"I really hope it isn't invisibility..." Blinker said, scrunching up her face.

"Uh, no. Not... not invisibility." Timothy said, realizing the implication of her words. "No uh, my power is... well, I'm a gamer! I gained access to something called the King Network!"

The room fell silent. Kar stared at Timothy with a stupid smile on his face, frozen as if waiting for a punchline. Blinker's stare was completely blank. She wasn't even sure what he'd said. Fiona looked at him with a hint of disbelief.

"G-gamer? Gaming? Your power is... video games?" Fiona asked, trying not to sound too disbelieving of his words. "That's... that's really nice, honey. So you're really good at playing video games, then?"

"What? No! That's not what I meant." Timothy said, feeling his stomach tighten. "I can use video game mechanics in real life! Look, like this..."

Timothy quickly looked around the room. He spotted a book Fiona had been reading, 'To Kill a Mockingbird', then walked over, grabbed it, and right in front of everyone, he put it into his inventory.

From their perspective, Timothy seemed to just... make the book disappear.

Kar's frozen smile cracked slightly. He tried to continue grinning, but the expression was becoming increasingly strained. "Hurgh. That's... uh... really impressive, Game Boy. What a fascinating, uh, power you have..."

"You can make things disappear?" Blinker asked, more confused than anything else. "So it is invisibility after all!"

"No, no, it's not invisibility." Timothy explained, feeling a spike of frustration. "Look, you know how in RPGs, characters can gain stats and skills to enhance themselves? I can do that now, but in real life!"

Kar's smile finally broke. He looked at his wife in absolute confusion. "Hurgh. What is *Arr Pee Geez*? I do not understand the words Game Boy is saying."

Neither he nor Blinker had ever played a video game. Fiona had played them with Timothy a little bit when he was still a kid, but she wasn't into them much and stopped when he was ten or eleven years old.

"So..." Fiona said carefully. "You can... use game mechanics in real life? That's what you're saying?"

"Yes!" Timothy said, grasping onto the faint string of hope he had left. "Like, uh, I can kill monsters, earn experience, and then level up to get powerful skills and abilities. I can also turn other people into video game players! I already used this ability on Ferral, so he's a Player like me, now!"

"Ferral is?" Fiona asked. "Timothy, you're not... making all this up, are you? What have I told you about fibbing?"

"Mom, come on, I'm being completely serious." Timothy said.

The young man paused for a moment. He looked off to the side at his UI tabs.

The Quests tab was glowing.

Timothy's eyes metaphorically flashed. He quickly tapped the air with his finger, revealing that the [Talk to Your Mother] and [Pick Flowers] quests had both been completed.

"One minute. Let me check something." Timothy said.

The other three stared at Timothy in bewilderment. For some reason, the young man started looking at absolutely nothing, touching his lip, muttering under his breath, and doing other bizarre behavior. It was as if he was seeing something they weren't.

"Is... is Timothy alright?" Blinker whispered to Kar. "Don't tell me he's gone mad and started hallucinating?"

"I do not know, Butterfly." Kar said quietly. "Hurgh. He did something to that book. You saw it. It vanished right in front of us."

"You don't think maybe it was some elaborate magic trick?" Blinker asked.

"Maybe. I am not certain..."

While they quietly talked, Timothy was examining his quests tab. He accepted the reward for [Pick Flowers], and then he checked his Character Sheet. A new Skill had appeared!

Your Mother's Smile: [Passive] [Unique] [Cooldown 1 Hour]

When your mother is happy, you are happy. Each time your mother genuinely smiles and feels happiness, if you are the cause of that smile, your accumulated Fatigue will decrease by 20%. You will also gain a mood boost, which will improve Mental Focus by

15% for one hour. Finally, this skill grants a passive 50% chance to recover from Mood debuffing status ailments when in the presence of your mother.

Timothy blinked. What a strange skill. It was a Unique skill, so it would definitely be of great benefit to him, but it felt rather bizarre how he had earned it.

"Never mind that..." Timothy muttered under his breath. "I can't use it to prove the King Network exists. Oh! What about this?"

Timothy accepted the rewards from the Main Story quest he'd just completed, [Talk to Your Mother].

He obtained 12 EXP, and when he looked at his character page, he found that he was at 12/100. Still a ways away from his first level up.

But he did obtain something concrete. A Tier 1 Lootbox!

Timothy summoned the box into his hands. When it appeared, the other three stared with wide-eyes. Timothy held a plain wooden box in his hand, maybe the size of a small book. Faint glowing runes were etched on the box, and the words 'Tier 1' were barely visible among them.

"You see??" Timothy asked, turning to them. "I'm not making it up! This is my first ever Lootbox. Let's see what it gives..."

He manually opened the box. At once, a bright, magical light erupted from inside, spilling out of the edges and briefly lighting up the room, even if only a little. The light faded, and three tiny orbs shot out of the box, suspending themselves in the air before Timothy. He stared hungrily as the orbs suddenly turned into large light boxes with an image and text describing the rewards.

On cue, Umi materialized beside Timothy, her light orb only visible to him.

"**Lootboxes are a mechanic designed to allow the Player to make important choices that will affect their future progression. You are offered multiple items, skills, or abilities, and may only choose one option. Later on, you may acquire the ability to re-roll your rewards, banish them permanently so that you will never see them again, or lock a reward so that you can obtain it in the next future lootbox of the same or higher tier.**"

Timothy noticed several nuanced hints in what she'd just told him. "So I can only pick one option, but the options I don't pick can still show up in the future. Interesting."

Timothy then looked at the items carefully.

Climbing Claws: [Item] [Uncommon] [Hand Slot] [Utility/Offense]

A set of gloves the Player can wear with extremely sharp fingertips. These will allow the Player to climb nearly any surface without losing their grip, even if the Player is completely exhausted. They also offer a slashing damage bonus if the Player fights with them unarmed, and they offer bonus grip to melee weapons so the Player is less likely to drop them. This bonus is halved for two-handed weapons.

Teleportation Orb: [Item] [Common] [Consumable] [Utility/Traversal]

A magical orb the Player can place or throw, then activate with a mental command to teleport to the Orb's location. The Common variant can only be used five times before it permanently dissipates. Alternatively, if the Teleportation Orb has not been used, the Player can craft a Beacon with it to teleport to a fixed location through Fast Travel.

Call Finch: [Active Skill] [Common] [Summon] [Mana Cost 5]

Summon a small bird which can be ordered around. The Player can converse with the Finch and exchange information. The Player can also remotely pilot the Finch and temporarily take over its consciousness. Seizing control will only last for a maximum of five minutes. The Finch is extremely fragile, and if it dies, the skill will disappear.

Timothy gasped audibly. These were the weakest, shittiest tier 1 items and skills he could obtain, and they were all awesome! He couldn't believe what he was seeing!

He looked over at his mother, Kar, and Blinker, but... they didn't look as impressed as him.

"So?" Kar asked. "What does that box do?"

"You don't see this?" Timothy asked, gesturing to the three floating windows in front of him.

The other three slowly shook their heads.

"You opened the box and started randomly making weird faces and noises." Blinker said.

"Didn't you guys see the bright light when I opened the box?" Timothy asked.

"Nope." Blinker replied.

Timothy felt a little annoyed. Here he was, trying to prove that his power was real, but the damned System was doing everything it could to make him look like a fraud!

Frustrated, Timothy looked at the three things on offer.

"Well then, I'd better pick something that makes it obvious I'm not faking this. I really want to pick Call Finch, but I don't have any MP yet. It's still at 0. The teleportation orb seems cool, but the Climbing Claws are Uncommon, and they seem generally useful..."

He made his decision. If he had any mana, he would have picked the little bird for sure, but the Climbing Claws were the most practical thing he could choose right now. Plus, they looked really cool.

As he tapped the Climbing Claws, the other two items vanished. The Lootbox abruptly levitated into the air, then it dissolved into nothingness, vanishing from existence. A faint speck of light appeared, which then materialized into his chosen item.

The Climbing Claws!

The simple but elegant gloves fell out of the air and landed in Timothy's grasp. When they appeared, the expressions on the other three's faces finally changed.

"Oh! What is that?" Kar asked. "Gloves? Perhaps gauntlets?"

"They look like metal claws." Blinker said, walking closer to Timothy to get a better look. "They seem really sharp. You'd better be careful, Timothy."

"Is that your power in action?" Fiona asked, walking over to rest her hand on her son's shoulder. "It... made a pair of gauntlets?"

"That's right." Timothy said. He looked at the gloves, and with a thought, they suddenly popped onto his hands. He didn't even need to put them on manually, he could equip them in an instant!

That drew another gasp of amazement from the others. By now, they'd observed enough metaphysical phenomena to believe he wasn't making things up.

"So the way my power works..." Timothy said, finally launching into a detailed explanation.

Minutes passed. An hour.

Blinker and Kar were not like Ferral. They had not played video games, and didn't really understand the mechanics of them. He had to explain concepts multiple times, much to his frustration, but eventually, they got the gist of the idea.

"So when you complete Quests, you get rewards, and the reward from telling me about your powers was this Lootbox." Fiona summarized.

"Exactly." Timothy said. "I've only just started using my power, so I don't know how everything works yet. But there's a Fast Travel system, so I think I might be able to use it to leave Chrona! Only if I find one of dad's Beacons, though."

"Whoa whoa, not so fast." Blinker interrupted. "You definitely can't leave Chrona, even if your power has a way to make that happen. Have you forgotten? If you leave, your body will implode when you re-enter Realspace. It nearly killed me last time I did it, and the time dilation wasn't nearly as bad as it is now. You definitely don't want to risk dying!"

"But you did survive." Timothy pointed out. "Sentients with enhanced bodies can resist the effects of temporal distortion! If I become strong enough, I should be able to make it to Realspace."

"It's still a no from me, young man." Fiona said. "For now, at least. You need to learn how this power of yours works before you even consider going out there. Let me remind you, you are the son of the Wordsmith. If any demon finds out who you are, or any Volgrim for that matter, they'll murder you without hesitation. Especially if they learn you have powers! Jason was a serious threat to humanity's enemies. That's why they killed him."

"Yeah." Blinker said sullenly. "Gressil murdered your father, and probably your mother too. He's a really scary demon. If he can nullify your powers, you'll be meat on the chopping block. It's best if you stay in Chrona for now."

Timothy wanted to leave, but he wasn't ready to throw his life away. His mother's words, as well as Blinker's, served to put him on more stable mental footing.

"You're right. I shouldn't rush. I have plenty of time, now that I've unlocked my powers. I might as well focus on leveling up so I can become a badass!"

Timothy glanced at his Quests. Already, there were new ones replacing the old.

[Story] Escape Chrona.

You were born in a time-accelerated realm, and as such cannot exist in Realspace without finding a way to counter Time Dilation Sickness. Neutralize the effects of Time Dilation Sickness, or become strong enough that you can ignore them, then exit Chrona's confines.

Rewards: [2x Level Up], 2x Lootbox Tier 2, 1x Enchantment Orb.

[Side Quest] Use Your Equipment

You've chosen the Climbing Claws. Locate the tallest building in Chrona and climb to the top. Doing so in under 3 minutes will double your rewards.

Rewards: [27 EXP], 1x Reroll Token, 1x Banish Token.

[Side Quest] Invite Additional Players

Your Party can consist of up to four people, including yourself. For each additional Sentient you invite to your party, you will be rewarded. Be warned: Inviting the wrong people can create a future problem. Only choose those you can trust.

Rewards (Per invited Player): [1x Level Up], 1x Lootbox Tier 3, 3x Random Stat Booster.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Training With Ferral.

You and Ferral are both Newbies, but Ferral is a stronger Sentient than you. Train your combat skills with him to increase your capabilities.

Rewards: [3 EXP], 3x Lootbox Tier 1.

[Side Quest] Conquer the Volgrim Empire.

The Volgrim Empire is in crisis. Billions of innocents are dying every day to the Plague. Come up with a way to save the Empire and install yourself as its new leader.

Rewards: [860,723,441 EXP], 714x Lootbox Tier 10, 41x Prestige Points, Multiclass Support Added, 3x Unique Skills, (15 Others)

Timothy examined the new quests, and the old ones as well. He found it rather suspicious that the rewards for inviting other people to the King Network were so extravagant considering the relative ease of doing so. At present, he could only repeat the inviting process twice before he ran out of Party slots… but still! An entire level up just for inviting someone?

Timothy glanced at Fiona.

Mom is an ordinary human, or rather, a spiritual life form. Does that mean she'll be able to level up at 100% efficiency, like me?

He looked at Blinker.

She's definitely an ascended life form. She'd probably have bigger debuffs placed on her than Ferral did since she's as strong as a Demon Emperor! It probably isn't worth it to invite the Monster Queen...

He looked at Kar.

Uncle Kar used to be even stronger than Blinker. But he's crippled now, unable to exercise without injuring himself. Would the System considering him an ascended life form like Ferral and penalize him? Or since he's so weak from his injuries, would he be given a standard EXP rate like me? Crocodiles are innately powerful... so he should be considered stronger than a baseline human.

Timothy tapped his lower lip thoughtfully. Ultimately, he didn't have a good answer for his question. Of the three, Kar and Fiona seemed like the best options, but there *were* others in Chrona he could invite. And maybe his mom and Kar wouldn't be interested anyway? They didn't care much about video games.

"Well, mom." Timothy eventually said. "I just wanted you and the others to know. I'm gonna go use my powers and try leveling up to make myself stronger. The System says if I train with Ferral, I can get big rewards."

"That's a good idea, sweetheart." Fiona said, smiling at her son. She sniffed the flowers he gave her and beamed brightly with happiness. Immediately, Timothy felt some of his fatigue disappear as he observed his mother's happy smile. "Don't do anything rash, but do have fun. From what I know of your father, obtaining Heroic powers can be so very, very thrilling."

Timothy smiled back. "I love you, mom. I promise from now on, I'm going to turn over a new leaf. This is only the start of my journey."

Kar chuffed. "Hurgh. That it is!"

Part 682: Truth and Desire

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

"TIMOTHY EDWARD HIRO! What are you DOING? Get down from there!!"

Fiona screamed in horror as she looked up at the residential apartment zone where so many crocodiles lived, less than three blocks west of the Spynet Sphere. A tiny but unmistakable figure was climbing the sheer brick wall with no ropes or pulleys to save him if he slipped and fell. Who else could it be other than her foolish son, Timothy?!

Timothy moved quickly. A three-minute timer ticked down on the left side of his vision, the time limit for him to earn double the rewards from this quest. Unfortunately, he hadn't expected his mom to step out of the Spynet and spot him less than a minute after he started climbing.

"One sec, mom!!" Timothy shouted without looking back. He continued to climb while he talked. "I gotta get to the top!"

"TIMOTHYYY!!" Fiona shrieked, feeling like she was about to have a heart attack.

Blinker quickly stepped out of the Spynet, she easily spotted Timothy's conspicuous form, but didn't make an immediate move to fly over and rescue him.

"Calm down, Fiona. I'm here now. If he starts to fall, I'll catch him with my magic."

"What is he doing?!" Fiona cried. "He's going to get himself killed! When did my son become such a thrill-seeking daredevil?"

"He must have wanted to try out those gauntlets. Remember? The Climbing Claws?" Blinker half-correctly guessed, unaware he'd received a quest to do so. "I know you're scared, but I'm here now. I won't let anything happen to him."

Blinker flapped her wings. She launched toward Timothy and flew to a spot just behind him, frowning when she saw Timothy scaling the wall much faster than should have been possible.

Each time Timothy willed it, one of his claws would stop gripping the wall, then he could pull himself up and hook that claw to the next climbing position. They didn't dig into the walls, and they didn't even leave marks. They clearly functioned off magical principles, but Blinker wasn't certain what those principles were.

"Kid, you're really scaring the daylights out of your mom." Blinker said.

"I know! Sorry! Just leave me alone for another minute! I gotta make it to the top... and don't help me, either!" Timothy shouted.

He was getting tired. The Climbing Claws took the fear of falling out of the equation, but lifting his entire body, arm length by arm length, still required incredible strength and endurance to pull off. Since he only had Climbing Claws and not Climbing Boots, his feet were nearly useless. Timothy was not athletic at all. He was a nerd who simply played a lot of video games, and as such, had wildly underestimated how much stamina it would take to scour the building. He stupidly assumed the claws would do all the work, but he couldn't have been more wrong.

The further he climbed, the more ragged Timothy's breathing became. He gasped and wheezed, cursing himself for not doing pushups and pullups in his youth. Maybe he could have been more prepared for when he got his powers! Of course, he'd had no way of knowing, back then.

The seconds ticked down. Only thirty remained. Timothy had made it to the ninth floor, and the tenth floor was within reach. He'd scaled the first three floors quickly, but after the fourth, things became harder and harder. Now he wasn't sure if he could make it or not.

"Guh! Can't... can't give up!" Timothy growled to himself.

He summoned a burst of willpower he didn't even know he had and frantically increased his speed. It wasn't much, but compared to his previous pace, it was positively explosive. Every two seconds, he pulled himself up another arm's length.

"Come on, you... mother... fucker!!" Timothy cursed at himself, as the edge of the rooftop came within an arm's length. He grabbed on, held the edge for three long seconds, then as the timer was in its final two seconds, he gave himself a massive heave and yanked with all his strength, pulling himself over the edge and toppling onto the rooftop, exhausted and mentally broken.

"Oh... oh god... kuhuk! Guh... shit, that was... ugh..."

Timothy had never exerted himself physically that much in his entire life. He had never gone for a run, or played on monkey bars, or done other stuff kids often did with

their friends at school. He was a total recluse who had little idea how the real world worked.

Even so, after gasping for breath and crying over his burning lungs, Timothy couldn't help but wheeze out a pained laugh.

"Ha.. haha... I did... I did it... not a loser... not gonna be a loser anymore... haha..."

Blinker flew up and landed beside him. She crossed her arms and looked down at the young man disapprovingly.

"What were you thinking? Too eager to play with your new toys?"

Timothy looked at her. He wanted to raise a hand, but he couldn't. His arms had lost all their strength.

"Quest... I had a quest... to climb the building." Timothy coughed. "Had to do it quick... less than three minutes. Sorry for scaring mom..."

"Oh, so it was that game power's doing." Blinker said, her arms relaxing a little. "Still, you could have told me. I'd have flown you up here if you needed to get to the top so badly."

Timothy spent a few seconds silently breathing, reducing the burn in his lungs. He shakily sat up, his head wobbling from dizziness.

"That wouldn't work, auntie." Timothy said slowly. "I had to climb by using my own power. Now, let's see if I succeeded..."

Timothy checked his Quests. He was delighted to see that the climbing quest wasn't flashing red like other completed quests, but it was flashing silver!

[Side Quest] Use Your Equipment - COMPLETE! [Silver Ranking]

You have completed the timed objective, and have earned double the stated rewards. However, you failed to complete the Gold Time Record, and have thus failed to earn triple rewards.

Rewards earned: [2x27 EXP], 2x Reroll Token, 2x Banish Token.

Timothy looked at the quest in disbelief.

"Hey, Umi. What's this about a Gold Time Record?"

Umi's orb of light materialized next to Timothy. "**Completing a timed quest will earn the standard reward. Completing a timed quest within the allotted time**

will earn double the rewards. Completing a timed quest in half the required time will triple the rewards."

"What?! In half the time?! That's ridiculous! There's no way I could have pulled that off! More importantly, why didn't you tell me about the Gold Time thing! It would have been nice to know!"

Blinker listened as Timothy cursed at something called 'Umi'. She felt that this name was familiar, but she wasn't sure where she had heard it before... somewhere, a long time ago, maybe?

"**The King Network judged that the Gold Time was barely within your capabilities. Thus, informing you of the Gold Time would not have served any useful purpose.**" Umi replied. "**You may collect your rewards now.**"

Timothy grumbled and cursed under his breath, but at least he'd learned about the secret Gold reward in a low stakes environment, like now. When he combined his 54 EXP with the 12 EXP from earlier, he was at 66 EXP, 2/3rds of the way toward his first level-up. He couldn't wait to see what would happen!

As an added bonus, he had acquired two Rerolls and two Banishes for future Lootboxes. Those would certainly turn out to be quite handy.

After Timothy had recovered from his exhaustion, he shakily rose to his feet, and Blinker, in her human-sized form, helped him stand.

"Hey, who is Umi?" Blinker asked. "Her name sounds... familiar."

"It does?" Timothy asked. "Well, someone named The Creator made the King Network, and he assigned Umi to be the tutorial companion."

"Ohh... I see." Blinker said, looking at him strangely. "So, do you want to climb down yourself, or...?"

"No, no, I'd love it if you can help me get back down, auntie. I'm beat." Timothy said, his arms twitching from over-exertion.

Blinker levitated both of them into the air, then she flew Timothy back to the Spynet, where his mother had mostly regained her calm. Kar was standing beside her, looking positively unruffled about all Timothy's crazy antics.

"...Just what exactly were you thinking?" Fiona snapped, when Timothy arrived.

"The System gave me a quest, and it seemed easy, so I decided to do it." Timothy explained. "It wanted me to scale the tallest building in Chrona, and it would double my rewards if I could do so in under three minutes."

"So that's why." Fiona said. Her frown deepened. "And if this 'System' tells you to jump off a bridge for rewards, will you do that too?"

"Mom, come on, it's not like that." Timothy complained. "These Climbing Claws are the real deal. I tested them first just to be sure I would be safe. They adhere to walls magically, and there's no risk of them losing their grip or my hands sliding out. Here, why don't you try putting them on to see for yourself?"

Fiona didn't move when Timothy unequipped the gloves and they appeared in his grasp. He held them out to her, but she didn't take them.

"Even if you took the necessary precautions, you should have told me what was going on." Fiona muttered. "You scared the daylights out of me."

"Hurgh. White Ghost is right." Kar affirmed. "It is good that you took precautions, but you should have told someone what you were doing. We were standing right here, after all. You could have told us on the way out the door."

"I, uh, didn't want you guys to worry about me." Timothy said lamely.

"More like you knew I'd say no!" Fiona exclaimed. "But whatever. At least you're fine. Timothy, you are soon going to be a man. You're almost 18. I can't protect you forever, and I certainly shouldn't. But just because you want to be a big, independent man, that doesn't mean you shouldn't let others know what you're up to! Even your father told me where he was going. The only time he didn't... well, that was when Gressil..."

Fiona trailed off. She glanced at the ground, momentarily lost in an old memory.

"I'm really sorry, mom." Timothy apologized. "Look, I'm going to go back to my room and rest. I'll train with Ferral tomorrow, and if I get any other dangerous quests, I'll tell you, okay?"

Fiona nodded. "Okay."

She rubbed her arms, visibly aggrieved. Timothy hesitated, then stepped forward and lifted his weak limbs to embrace his mom. She brightened up a little and hugged him back, clearly just glad he wasn't injured.

As they hugged, Blinker looked at Kar. "Honey, does the name 'Umi' ring a bell for you?"

Kar nodded. "Of course! Hurgh. Have you forgotten? Umi is the name of my mother's AI creation. Umi runs the Remnant Oasis."

Blinker's eyes shot open. "Oh my gosh! So that's where I've heard the name! But wait, why is Umi part of Timothy's game power?"

"She is?" Kar asked.

"She is??" Fiona exclaimed, pulling out of her son's embrace. "Wait, what's all this about Umi? What's going on?"

Timothy, visibly confused, looked between the three adults. With slight hesitation, he explained Umi's role in the System and how she functioned.

"Why can't we see Umi? Is she with you now?" Fiona asked.

Timothy nodded. "Only Players can see Umi. She's floating right there, and she looks like a marble-sized light orb."

Fiona's expression turned bizarre. "Why would Umi be involved in all of this? Did she manipulate the Queen Network? Duplicate it to make the King Network? How does it relate to Timothy's powers? And what does the Creator have to do with all of this? Something isn't adding up."

"We should call Rebecca over." Blinker suggested. "She knows more about Marie than anyone here except for maybe Kar."

And so they did. Rebecca was busy repairing a solar power converter, but she readily agreed to head over when she heard the news. Less than ten minutes later, the green-haired Cybernite jogged over and stopped when she drew close enough to the others to walk the rest of the way.

"What's this business with Umi?" Rebecca asked.

Fiona explained the situation. Rebecca's expression didn't change.

"How odd." She said, her blank face making it seem as if she thought the situation was perfectly ordinary. "Timothy, can you ask Umi if Marie Becker has anything to do with the King Network?"

Timothy nodded. "Umi, is Marie Becker affiliated with the King Network?"

When Umi said next astonished him.

"**Certain details about the inner workings of the King Network are locked from Player access until they reach a certain milestone.**"

"What milestone?" Timothy asked in bewilderment. "What does that mean?"

"**Certain details about the inner workings of the King Network are locked from Player access until they reach a certain milestone.**" Umi repeated. "**Further queries regarding this matter will be ignored.**"

Timothy looked at his mom. "Umi basically says she can't tell us anything."

"That's extremely suspicious." Fiona replied. She looked at Kar. "Marie never told you anything about making some real life game system for Timothy?"

"Mother never said anything of the sort." Kar answered. "Hurgh. You are correct. This is all very suspicious. How can we be certain this is the same 'Umi' my mother made? Maybe it is an impersonator?"

Timothy tapped his chin. "We could call over Ferral. He has access to the System too."

"Yes. Let's do that." Blinker said.

* * *

A few minutes later, Ferral levitated over at a fast but unhurried speed. It vaguely seemed as if his aerial agility had increased, but Timothy couldn't be certain.

When Ferral landed, he smiled with his eyes at Timothy. [Congratulations on completing multiple Quests. I hope you have reaped fine rewards.]

Timothy looked at his friend in surprise. "How do you know I completed my quests?"

[Because.] Ferral said slowly. [I enabled the 'Party Log' in the Options menu. Did you not see it?]

Timothy shook his head. "There's so many options I figured I'd look at them later."

[I contemplate, and I comprehend.] Ferral said gracefully. [I can already see that you have completed the *Use Your Equipment* quest, as well as the *Talk to Your Mother* and *Pick Flowers* quests.]

The moment Ferral finished speaking, Timothy's heart skipped a beat. He turned to look at his mom, only to see Fiona with an expression of shock.

"What!" Fiona shouted. "You're telling me that picking me flowers was all part of one of those... those game quests?!"

"N-no, mom, it's not like that!" Timothy hurriedly explained. "I already wanted to pick you flowers, and the System-"

He didn't finish. The look his mother gave him broke his heart.

"This... is so humiliating..." Fiona whispered, looking down as tears started to form at the edges of her eyes. "I thought... I thought you did it because you genuinely... but it was just... just because of your game!!"

Unwilling to burst into tears in front of everyone, Fiona quickly turned away, then she hurried into the Spynet and slammed the door, locking it from within.

Timothy stood perfectly still, like a statue, his face frozen in shock. He didn't intend for his mom to find out, but Ferral had blabbered the one thing he shouldn't right in front of her. When Timothy looked at Ferral, Ferral met his gaze with pure confusion.

[I do not comprehend. Why is your mother in distress?] Ferral asked.

Blinker's expression turned ugly. "Because that 'nice gesture' Timothy made was only because his game system told him to do it! Good lord, Timothy! Can't you do anything right? Now you've made your mother cry AGAIN!"

Timothy's heart fell into his shoes. For the first time, he felt that the System wasn't as benign as it seemed. He followed its prompts, but in doing so, he hurt the people around him again and again.

"I... I didn't mean to... I just thought when I saw the quest that mom would like the flowers. I wasn't going to tell her." Timothy mumbled.

"And you think that makes it better?" Blinker asked. "Because you were going to lie to her? Timothy, you've really exercised questionable judgment for the entirety of today. You owe your mom a serious apology!"

Timothy lowered his head. He felt like an absolute piece of shit. He'd never felt as low as he did at this moment. Even being caught peeping wasn't as bad as this.

The last 24 Chrona-hours had been a roller-coaster of emotions for him, but the lowest lows were far worse than the highest highs.

Just when he thought he couldn't feel any more rotten, something popped up right in front of his face.

[Emergency Quest!] Apologize To Your Mom

You have severely hurt your mother's feelings. You should apologize to her as soon as possible. A nice bouquet of roses would go a long way toward mending relations. Completing the apology within the next hour will result in doubling the reward bonuses! Failure to complete the objective within one hour will result in the loss of the [Mother's Smile] skill.

Rewards: [1x Level Up] [1x Tier 1 Skill] [1x Tier 1 Runestone]

"FUCK!" Timothy shrieked, grabbing his hair. "What the fuck?! Right now? Seriously?? This- I don't even know what to do now! This is so fucked up!"

Blinker flinched. She didn't expect him to erupt into anger. "What are you talking about?"

"It just gave me another quest!" Timothy seethed, balling his hands into fists and pressing them hard against the sides of his skull. "The System wants me to apologize to my mother within the next hour! It'll reward me if I do, but punish me if I don't! What kind of sick game is this? I already wanted to apologize to her, but now if I do it, won't I just be doing it for a goddamn REWARD? This is so unfair! I can't do anything right, and it's all because of this stupid fucking video game bullshit!"

He violently tugged at his hair, almost as if wanting to rip his scalp off. Timothy had never felt so hurt, confused, and angry in his entire life. He felt like he'd become the pawn of some evil god, a god trying desperately to ruin his life, or at the very least toy with his emotions!

He didn't know what to do. He wanted to apologize to his mother, but if he did, wouldn't he just be doing what the system intended for him to do again?!

Just as Timothy was reaching the boiling point, Ferral reached out and grabbed his shoulder.

[Timothy. You must regain your center of calm.]

"Calm?" Timothy retorted, giving him a bewildered look. "How can I possibly be calm? This is so fucked up! Don't you think this whole System thing is acting like a piece of shit toward us? Toward me??"

Ferral remained unmoved. He squeezed Timothy's arm a little harder.

[Timothy. You are my closest friend. I am asking you, as your closest friend, to please calm down. I may be able to offer an explanation.]

Timothy's chest rose and fall. He stared at Ferral, feeling as if part of this was all Ferral's fault for blabbering about the damn quest right in front of his mother.

But at the same time, it was Timothy's fault for doing what the quest told him to do! He didn't know if he should be madder at Ferral, himself, or Umi!

Several seconds passed. Under Ferral's focused gaze, Timothy forced himself to take several long, deep breaths. His momentary rage slightly faded away. He turned to stare at the ground, now more confused than angry.

[Thank you.] Ferral said calmly. He released his grip on Timothy's shoulder, then turned to look at Blinker and Kar. [I ask that you intervene in this matter between Timothy and his mother. Timothy is not fully aware of how the King Network functions, and neither am I, but I have contemplated its nature since I obtained it, and have chanced upon a most interesting facet of its design.]

"What do you mean?" Kar asked.

[The King Network is not a simple creation. It is a technological and magical marvel. Its abilities border on the edge of impossibility. I cannot begin to explain how it functions or how it was created. But while I was training to complete one of my quests, I took the time to speak with Umi and I noticed something interesting.]

He paused.

[The King Network's Quest function is directly related to the desires of each Player. Timothy possesses a quest he cannot possibly complete which requires him to subjugate the entire Volgrim Empire. I possess a similarly impossible quest, which is to reach the 10th Level of Psionics. I believe these quests are related to our deepest desires, in the same way Timothy wishes to apologize to his mother, and he wished to make amends to her through an offering of some sort. Hence the Pick Flowers quest.]

Timothy looked at Ferral with a hint of awe. "You're saying the Quests are shaped by Player desires? But how can that be true? I don't have any desire to conquer the Volgrim Empire. I've never even thought about it."

[Perhaps not consciously.] Ferral said, slowly blinking his eyes. [But you desire to become a powerful and revered Hero, like your father. What better way to achieve that goal than to take over the ruling power of the Milky Way? That is why it is a final goal. It is a logical conclusion to your life's future trajectory. As for the other lesser quests, those are the small stepping stones that may someday lead you to the greatness you seek.]

Ferral looked up at the pitch-black sky which held no stars. [I have a desire of my own. I wish to become powerful enough that I can travel the cosmos unhindered. I wish to gaze upon the beauty and ugliness of the universe. I have no interest in manipulating power to fight other power-seeking Sentients, but possessing great power will allow me to achieve my true goals. Thus, when I look at my Quests, I see a story the System has woven for me based on my desires.]

Ferral smiled with his eyes. [The King Network offered you this apology quest because it is the thing you most desperately wish to achieve right now. If you fail to apologize to your mother, it is not the System punishing you, but yourself. You will feel as if you are a terrible son undeserving of his mother's love.]

Timothy stared off into the distance. Ferral's words had hit him hard.

The King Network functioned based off the desires of its users. Timothy wanted to become a legendary Hero, like his father, and that meant he would need to grow. Thus, the System provided him with a ladder he could climb.

Ferral wanted to obtain the ultimate freedom to travel the cosmos. The system offered him a path to succeed.

Timothy looked at the Emergency Quest he had just unlocked. Its timer mercilessly continued to count down from one hour, and had already dropped below fifty minutes.

His fists unclenched. His heart softened.

"I see. So that's how it is." Timothy muttered.

He thought for another minute, while Blinker, Kar, Rebecca, and Ferral stayed silent, allowing him to stew.

"It was a misunderstanding." Timothy said quietly. "I still have a lot to learn about this Player power. I'm going to go in and apologize to my mom... but later. I'll give her some space for now. It's fine if I fail the quest. I want to apologize to her on my own terms."

"What about the punishment for failing?" Blinker asked.

"No silly quest reward matters more than making my mom smile." Timothy said. "I'll return later. Tell my mom... whatever you feel like. I'll apologize properly when she's had time to process her emotions."

Timothy stood up a little straighter. He turned and walked to his house, leaving the others to stare at his back as he departed.

Once he was gone, Rebecca looked around the assembled people.

"Pardon me, but I am ignorant regarding this 'game system'. Would someone be willing to fill me in on its specifics?"

Ferral nodded while spreading out his palms. [I would be pleased to enhance your comprehension.]

Part 683: Swim and Smash

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Two days passed inside Chrona.

Timothy apologized to his mother. He took a hit from the King Network and lost the skill that boosted him when his mother smiled, but in return, he was able to make progress in his own emotional development.

The young man was badly stunted. He wasn't sheltered, not deliberately, but growing up with almost no humans around him, especially ones his age, had negatively affected his development in a lot of ways.

On the other hand, it *had* made him a lot more... open minded.

Timothy sat on a bench in Chrona's central park area, beside a yellow-scaled crocodile girl. She gazed at him with eyes filled with awe.

"So it's like one of your vid-eyeo games? You can level up and stuff?"

"Yeah. Pretty cool, right?" Timothy said, leaning sideways against the bench with a smirk. "Check out these Climbing Claws. They let me climb any surface without falling! Unfortunately, I'm kind of... weak. So I get tired when I'm climbing fast."

"That's just because you're a human." The girl teased. "If you were a crocodile, you'd have big muscles. But I bet if you train at the gym, you can get lots and lots stronger!"

The girl's name was Marigold. She was technically born a few hours before Timothy entered Chrona, but by the time he had arrived, she'd already mostly matched his temporal age. They had gone to the same school growing up, along with three dozen other crocodiles from the same litter.

"I'm kinda nervous to go in there." Timothy admitted. "All the crocodiles train there. They'll think I'm weak and make fun of me."

"No way!" Marigold chuffed. "Kyargh! You're a Hero now! That means you're going to become a serious asset to Chrona in the future. Everyone will want to be your friend! I bet we can get Great Grandpa Remus to be your personal trainer. He's a first generation croc, you know. A first generation! If he whips you into shape, you'll become a powerhouse in no time."

Timothy glanced at his Character sheet. He was still Level 0, but he'd made it to 97/100 EXP. He was just a hair's breadth away from achieving his first level up.

Timothy licked his lips. He looked at Marigold, his eyes inadvertently roving up and down her scaled, muscular body. He quickly looked away. She was one of his crushes, but he'd never had the confidence to say anything to her. Even if she didn't look anything like a human girl, Timothy had been raised around crocodiles. He liked them just fine.

"Where are you looking?" Marigold teased.

Timothy coughed. "Uh, nowhere in particular!"

"Ahaha! You're so cute when you blush!" Marigold teased.

Just as Timothy was about to say something else, a notification popped up in front of him.

[Story Quest] Timothy, SMASH!

Marigold is your type. She's totally into you, just look at the way she's batting her eyes! You should quickly seduce her and take her to a private room. Gain additional rewards for each romance stage you progress!

First Base Rewards: [CHA Improved by 5%], [DEX Improved by 5%]

Second Base Rewards: [CHA Improved 5%], [DEX Improved by 5%]

Third Base Rewards: [Heat Resistance +10%], [Cold Resistance +10%]

Fourth Base Rewards: [STA Improved 10%], [STR Improved 10%]

Obtain Girlfriend: [Respect+] [Currency Gain +10%] [Experience Gain +10% (Permanent)]

Obtain Marriage: [STA Improved +50%], [Skill: Mental Resilience]

Note: All benefits except Permanent buffs will disappear if the relationship ends under negative terms.

Timothy's eyes nearly exploded out of his head. He coughed profusely, then excused himself, saying he'd just remembered he'd promised to do something for his mom. He left

Marigold sitting on the bench with question marks metaphorically hovering over her head.

After Timothy hurried out of range, he cursed under his breath. "Umi, *what the shit*?? I told you not to do that anymore! Goddammit, now I'm all in my head! I don't want to get rewarded just for doing the things I like in life!"

Umi blinked to life, materializing in front of Timothy. "**As Player Ferral has hypothesized, the King Network reacts to your desires. Clearly, your disgusting biological urges were deeply inclining you toward copulating with the female crocodile. As for me, I have no ability to create or influence Quests.**"

Timothy massaged his face madly, rubbing his hands up and down as if to scrub the sense of shame away. "God, it's so embarrassing! Is this going to happen with every girl I like? Am I going to turn all my important relationships into commodities? This isn't okay!"

Umi beeped. "**I do not see a problem. You will improve your relationships and obtain additional rewards to strengthen yourself. Isn't obtaining power exactly what you wanted?**"

Timothy paused. He leaned against a tree and stared at the ground. His stomach churned with nausea. He didn't know how to verbalize the feelings in his heart, but gamifying everything in his life was slowly turning from a great gift into a serious emotional burden.

"I... I do want to become stronger." Timothy mumbled. "But not like this. Can't you just give me quests to slay monsters, or to train my body, or to search for treasure? Why do the quests have to keep involving my personal life? It's really messed up."

"**The King Network operates based on your conscious and subconscious desires. There is nothing I can do to influence it. I am only the tutorial companion.**" Umi blandly answered.

Timothy grunted. He dismissed Umi with a wave of his hand, then sat on the ground at the base of the tree. He felt like scum once again, ashamed of who he was, ashamed of his animal instincts fighting against his conscious thoughts.

Was it really okay to do quests if they would commodify his relationships? He was going to do them anyway, right? Surely, there wasn't any harm...

Timothy wanted to cry. Somehow, becoming a Hero had made him feel more isolated and alone than when he lurked in his bedroom all day and wasted his life away. He didn't know what he wanted anymore. Two days of grinding out quests, and he wasn't even sure if he wanted to do this stuff anymore.

"Timothy? Are you okay?"

A girl's voice startled Timothy. He looked up to see Marigold standing there, looking at him with faint worry.

"Did I say something wrong?" Marigold asked quietly. "Kyargh! You ran away so suddenly, I thought maybe I'd offended you..."

Timothy did everything he could to stifle those tears that were threatening to erupt. He shook his head and looked at the ground. "Uh, no, it's not you, Marigold. I... I just. I'm sorry. I wanted- but then my power, and it made me... so then..."

Marigold blinked at him in confusion.

"Timothy, you don't seem okay. Why don't you tell me what's going on?"

She walked over and sat beside him, looking off into the distance.

The two remained quiet for a time. Timothy wrapped his arms around his legs and buried his face in his knees.

"I'm... I feel lost, Marigold. I don't like what this System is doing to me. It doesn't feel right."

"What doesn't feel right about it?" She asked. "It sounded pretty great when you explained it to me earlier."

"Yeah..." Timothy muttered. "It *seems* great. But it makes me feel like a scumbag. I don't know how to act. It's..."

He paused. He looked up, then turned his head to look at the crocodile girl. She met his gaze.

"Yes?" Marigold prompted.

Timothy licked his lips. He looked away again. "The System... it gives me Quests. These quests are based on what I want out of myself, out of life, and out of other people.

My desires, basically. A couple days ago, when I first got the System, it gave me a strange quest to pick some flowers for my mom."

Timothy finally broke down and decided to tell Marigold the truth. Maybe the perspective of an unbiased outsider who wasn't his direct family would help.

After a few minutes, Marigold looked just as sad as Timothy.

"Oh, that's awful. So your mom thought you didn't love her?"

"Yeah. I apologized, but I've felt our relationship change. She doesn't look at me the same anymore. Then, earlier, when I was talking to you, the System..."

Timothy paused. He really didn't want to say this part. It made him feel like absolute shit.

After a moment, his fear of what she would think faded somewhat. He reflexively started to speak, but he wasn't certain why.

"It... it popped up a Quest about... about you."

"About me?" Marigold asked. "What sort of quest?"

Timothy swallowed. The next words were excruciatingly painful for him to say.

"It... it suggested... that if I were to get in a relationship with you, there would be, um... increasing rewards."

Marigold fell silent. She gave Timothy a strange look. Then she looked back off into the distance.

"Mar-Marigold?" Timothy said. "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have told you. This was a mistake-"

"It's okay." Marigold said, her voice low. "So your System thingy, it looks at what you want, and then it makes Quests based on those wants, right? Which meaaaans... you *want* to be in a relationship with me~?"

Marigold batted her eyes playfully.

Timothy froze. He simply didn't know how to react.

"W-well, I mean... yeah." Timothy said, feeling his body turn slightly numb. "I've always... um... liked you. I have a crush on you."

He nearly died from shame. He couldn't believe he'd just said those embarrassing words out loud!

Marigold chuffed cutely. "Kyargh! Timothy... I like you too! I always have. But I never get to see you. You're always at your house, never coming out to say hi to people. Geez, I'm really glad you like me!"

She smiled in that cute way only crocodile girls could. Timothy felt his ears start to heat up.

"You do?" Timothy asked. "But... but that isn't even the issue. The System-"

"I don't mind." Marigold said, her scales slightly flushing with a reddish color. "It gave you a quest because you like me, right? What's the problem with that? If we get together, I'm also helping humanity's future Hero out! Isn't that great?"

Timothy blinked. He was surprised she was... interested in him. Wasn't he a scrawny loser?

"I didn't know you liked me." Timothy said quietly. "I assumed you'd be interested in..."

"What? Big buff guys? Other crocodiles?" Marigold scoffed. "You know everyone else my age are my *brothers* right? And my uncles, and my nephews. It's really weird how many crocodiles are pursuing relationships with their close relatives. It feels kinda icky to me!"

Marigold shook her head. "But that's not important anyway. I like you because you've always been so... mysterious! You don't talk much, and you have this cute broody hair style... and you actually have hair! Some girls think human hair looks ugly, but I think it's cute! I really like how fluffy human heads are!"

Marigold started eagerly babbling listing off one reason after another why she liked Timothy. A lot of them were superficial, but he could hardly blame her. The two of them hadn't spoken a lot over the years, and she really only had his appearance to go off.

Still, Timothy felt more than a little flattered she found him so attractive. And she was tolerant of his moral dilemma with the System too.

Then... hadn't all his problems resolved themselves?

Timothy looked at Marigold. "You really like me?"

"Mhm!" Marigold nodded.

"Then... I guess... why don't we go on a date sometime?" Timothy suggested.

"Sure! Let's go swimming!" Marigold replied. "You know how to swim, right?"

"Of course I do. I'm surrounded by crocodiles!" Timothy laughed. "I might not be in good shape, but my swimming form isn't bad."

Marigold looked him up and down. "You know, swimming is one of the best ways to exercise your whole body. It's not as intense on specific muscles, but I bet if you kept swimming every day for half a year, you'd grow way stronger! And the more you swim, the faster you grow!"

Timothy smiled at her. But then, just as he was about to speak, his expression fell. He looked off to the side.

"What? What did I say?" Marigold asked.

"It's... ugh, it's not you. I just got another Quest." Timothy groaned.

"Oh! Is it a quest to go swimming with me?" Marigold asked.

Timothy nodded. "Yeah..."

"Well, that's great! Are you doing anything now? Let's head to the swimming hole!"

Timothy looked at the Quest that had just popped up.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Swimming with Marigold

It's a date, but it's also training! Go swimming with Marigold, and try to improve your relationship with her while getting in a good workout. Swim for at least one hour, with rewards doubled if you swim for two hours. Rewards can be earned from this quest once per day. If Marigold's affection for you increases past a certain point, other bonuses can be unlocked. (Note: Informing Marigold of this clause in any way will nullify those bonuses.)

Rewards: [1 EXP Per 5 Minutes spent Swimming], [Stamina Improved 5%], [1x Aquatic Lootbox (Only obtainable once)]

* * *

Timothy frowned. What bothered him was the new clause the System had put in that basically forced Timothy to withhold information from Marigold, even outright lying if she asked. Why was it constantly trying to turn him into a deceptive, lying asshole?

Timothy swallowed his grievances. Marigold seemed interested, and she was okay with helping him on his quests. Wasn't it alright to have some fun with her? He didn't have to take things so seriously.

"Alright, sure. Let me grab my swimming trunks and I'll meet you over at the swimming hole." Timothy said, smiling at Marigold again.

Marigold gave him a funny look. "You know crocodiles don't swim with anything on, right? You don't need to wear anything... *special*."

Timothy nearly fell over. Was she inviting him to swim in the nude? Well of course she was. That's how crocodiles swam, after all. And in truth, all crocodiles walked around naked unless they felt like donning ceremonial garb or wearing armor for additional protection.

Marigold was even naked right now, Timothy was just... not used to thinking in that way.

He blushed, then timidly nodded. "Yeah, uh, good point. Alright, we can go now."

He stood up, as did she. The two of them walked side-by-side across the city and out into the 'wilderness', small though it might seem, past several groups of other crocodiles. They easily picked up on Timothy and Marigold walking together, and a few of them even started loudly teasing the pair.

"Hey Timothy! Take her behind the school shed! That's a good place!" One of the teenaged male crocodiles shouted. He gave Timothy a huge thumbs up, then his friend laughed and slapped his back.

Timothy frowned. He wasn't used to being teased, and it made him self conscious.

"Don't worry about them." Marigold snorted in displeasure. "Bunch of muscle-brained idiots. Look! There's the swimming hole. It seems a few of my girlfriends are hanging out, too!"

Marigold waved cheerfully at a trio of other crocodile girls, all of whom sported different colored scales. All of them were her direct litter-mates, and therefore technically her sisters, but due to the incestful way of life the crocodiles had been forced to adopt in order to strengthen their numbers, inbreeding became a major issue.

Luckily, Jason and Fiona had come up with a way to randomize and diversify the genes of even crocodiles born within the same brood. Thus, the downsides of inbreeding

were minimized to the point of irrelevance. Still, the social stigmas existed and were offputting to some...

"Oh my gosh! Is that Timothy! Kyargh! Marigold, are you and Timothy *dating*?" One of the crocodile girls growled playfully. She was a blue-scaled croc Timothy knew from school named Genessa.

"Ahaha, maybe!" Timothy said, forcing a grin while scratching the back of his head. "That's a rather personal question to ask though, don't you think?"

"Pffft, you're funny!" Genessa laughed. "So are you coming here to swim? The water's nice and warm!"

Timothy glanced in the swimming hole. There wasn't exactly a lot of real estate in Chrona, and even though the artificial dimension was slowly expanding each year, an entire area dedicated to swimming was a luxury. It was extremely important to the crocodiles though, so a 100 meter in diameter hole had been dug out and filled with water. Its depth was half a kilometer, and thus it contained a large volume of water!

The pool was completely still. There was no moon to provide tidal activity, and the water was so clear that Timothy could see to the bottom. He'd come swimming lots of times when he was a kid, but the way the crocodiles outpaced him had slowly made him feel inferior until he was around ten years old and stopped coming.

Fish swam in the water below. There was a strict rule in Chrona that crocodiles could catch and eat the fish, but they must not puncture their bodies and create a bloody mess inside the swimming hole. It would pollute the water and could cause a serious health crisis. As such, there was always to be one senior crocodile watching the hole from above.

Timothy looked around. He spotted a tall tree where a female crocodile lifeguard of sorts sat on a branch, watching from above. She kept to herself and was only there to prevent any major 'incidents', as well as to keep an eye out for rambunctious youngsters spilling blood in the pool.

"Come on, Timothy!" Marigold chuffed. "Let's go swimming!"

Timothy blushed. Now that he was finally here, going in naked with a bunch of girls watching made him feel... uncomfortable. He didn't know how to act in a situation like this. It was extremely embarrassing.

After a moment though, his mind cleared up. The refreshment was almost a little bizarre. It felt as if a foreign entity had wiped away his fear, even if only for a few moments, and emboldened him. Uncertain why he would feel this way, Timothy decided to go along with the moment of bravery and strip off his shirt, his pants, and... even his underwear. He quickly jumped in the water while Marigold laughed at his boldness.

A timer appeared in Timothy's vision, one that started to count upward, with a listed goal of one hour.

The young man furrowed his brows. He wasn't here to do a Quest, but if it was going to offer him rewards, he wouldn't turn it down!

With that in mind, the buck naked young man started swimming around, moving around the edges of the pool and into the deeper areas. The edge of the swimming hole was somewhat shallow, usually less than 1.5 meters deep, but beyond that was the sheer 'cliff' underwater that led straight to the bottom. Timothy made sure not to stray too far past the edge. Dying a death of drowning would be excruciatingly painful.

Tens of minutes passed. An hour. Two hours.

Timothy started to really have fun. He laughed along with Marigold as they splashed each other. Soon, her friends joined in on the fun and went swimming too! He ended up swimming with four girls, and the experience felt... *good*. Arousing, even. Timothy had to go out of his way not to do anything weird that would scare the girls away.

Eventually, after doing entire laps around the edge of the swimming hole, Timothy crawled up on land and huddled around a fire to dry himself off. He tucked his legs in, feeling embarrassed again, then smiled at Marigold as she came to sit down beside him.

"Kyaaaargh! That was so much fun!" Marigold chirped. "You're a decent swimmer, but you need to improve your form. Did you have fun?"

"I did!" Timothy said. "This was a great idea. Thanks for cheering me up, Marigold. Where's Genessa and the others?"

Marigold batted her eyes. "Well, they um... they left. So we're here, all alone, hee-hee..."

"All alone?" Timothy repeated.

"Yes..."

Marigold folded her claws together and batted her eyes at him.

"Over behind that boulder, there's um, there's this little private spot..."

Timothy stared at her, incredulous.

It was that easy?

He nodded dumbly. "Yeah... why don't we go over there, then?"

What transpired next will be omitted.

Part 684: Levels and Loot!

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

In one afternoon, Timothy transformed from a boy into a man. He and Marigold intertwined their bodies together, making all kinds of lewd sounds as they both enjoyed the ecstasies of youth.

For Marigold, it was a great time, even if she and Timothy were inexperienced. For Timothy, it was not quite as enjoyable as he expected, mainly because it turned out sexing up a crocodile girl wasn't all sunshine and rainbows. Her cold-blooded body was frigid to the touch. This made her eager to get close to him to feel his warmth, but for him it was sort of like rubbing against a Popsicle.

And the chafing! Timothy felt as if he were having sex with cold sandpaper! He still enjoyed it, but some of the physical sensations weren't as warm and fuzzy as he'd expected.

Nevertheless, the two completed their ritual, and Timothy sagged on top of Marigold, breathing hard. His Quest tab flashed, but he ignored it. He wanted to enjoy this moment for what it was, at least for now.

Marigold looked at him with eyes full of adoration. "Kyargh! Human males are so much more romantic and loving than crocodiles! You should have heard the stories my sisters told me... their mates simply did the deed as quickly as possible before they left. You, um... you made me feel really good!"

"I... I really enjoyed... being with you..." Timothy said, cradling the back of her head with his hand. He kissed the tip of her snout and smiled. "I'm already, uh, looking forward to next time."

Marigold's scales flushed with color. "Yes... that is good, but... I mean, it's nobody's fault or anything... maybe you should have brought protection though? In the heat of the moment, we..."

Timothy looked down. His eyes widened.

"Oh! Oh no, uh... I mean... next time, I will for sure! But you don't think I might have...?"

"If spawnlings come, then so be it." Marigold said. "I wouldn't mind bearing the child of a Hero! I'll pray for multiple eggs!"

Timothy blanched. He liked Marigold, but he really hoped their first night wouldn't result in a pregnancy! That would be terrible. He wasn't even an adult yet!

Seeing the look on his face, Marigold's expression dimmed. "You... wouldn't want to take responsibility?"

"I would." Timothy said firmly. "Don't worry about it. Besides, you're immortal, and I can probably turn myself immortal with my System. What's a decade or two raising some kids, eh?"

"Hahaha! Kyargh, you're so funny sometimes!" Marigold chirped.

Some time later, the two of them got up. Timothy awkwardly took a quick dip in the water to get himself clean, then he dried himself by the fire and put his clothes back on.

He finally looked at the Quests screen.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Swimming with Marigold - COMPLETE!

It's a date, but it's also training! Go swimming with Marigold, and try to improve your relationship with her while getting in a good workout. Swim for at least one hour, with rewards doubled if you swim for two hours. Rewards can be earned from this quest once per day. If Marigold's affection for you increases past a certain point, other bonuses can be unlocked. (Note: Informing Marigold of this clause in any way will nullify those bonuses.)

Rewards: [1 EXP Per 5 Minutes spent Swimming], [Stamina Improved 5%], [1x Aquatic Lootbox (Only obtainable once)]

Note: Due to swimming for two hours and seventeen minutes, you have doubled this quest's rewards and obtained a total of 56 EXP, 10% improved Stamina, and 2x Aquatic Lootboxes. Further repetitions of this quest will not earn any additional Lootboxes.

Note: You failed to raise Marigold's affection to a satisfactory level during this exercise. Bonus rewards are not available.

Timothy smiled when he saw the first note, but frowned when he saw the second.

"I failed to increase her affection level?" Timothy said softly to himself. He looked, but Marigold was nowhere in sight.

Timothy pondered this information. It sure seemed as if she liked him a lot. Was she lying? Was she deceiving him? Or did the System somehow want him to become soulmates with her after just one afternoon of swimming? Maybe the level of affection it required was just barely higher than what he achieved? Or maybe it was insanely strict on its demands?

Timothy shook his head. "It doesn't matter. Marigold likes me, and I like her. So what if the System doesn't show she rose to some arbitrary *Affection Value*? We made love... and it was amazing."

Timothy smiled again. He tapped the Claim Rewards button. Considering his time spent swimming, and the exp per five minutes which was then doubled, his exp shot from Level 0 with 97/100 EXP to Level 1 with 53/118 EXP.

He was already halfway to the next level!!

Timothy grinned so hard he felt as if the sides of his mouth were going to rip open. "I did it! Yes!"

Marigold walked over upon hearing his shout. "What happened?"

"I leveled up!" Timothy said. "Let me see what happens next."

Marigold sat beside him, looking at him with a mixture of amusement and uncertainty. She couldn't see his System, but she could see the happiness on his face.

"You are so cute when you smile! Kyargh!"

"Haha, always teasing me." Timothy grinned, nudging her with his elbow.

A screen popped up in front of Timothy.

Level 1 Achieved.

First Reward: Full heal. Can be saved for later.

Second Reward: Choose one Common Equipment item from a selection of three.

Third Reward: Improve two of your skills by +1 levels. You cannot improve the same skill multiple times.

Fourth Reward: Choose a stat bonus from a selection of three.

Timothy's jaw dropped. It was like he'd obtained a free Lootbox, and he could buff his stats too! Not to mention a full heal he could bank for later?! That was like having a lifesaving Phoenix Down for emergencies!

He couldn't help himself. He spoke to the air. "Hey, Umi! Do I get these rewards during every level up?"

Marigold raised a quizzical eyebrow. Timothy shook his head. "Not you. My System has a robot tutorial companion named Umi."

The croc-girl nodded. "Oh."

Umi popped into existence. "**The King Network's rewards when leveling up are different for every level. They are usually quite generous though, especially as level-ups become harder to earn due to exponentially increasing experience requirements as a Player advances.**"

"Oh, yeah, good point." Timothy said, before reiterating what Umi told him to Marigold.

"You have a woman who answers your questions? And I can't see her?" Marigold asked. She looked a little jealous, like she was pouting.

"Not a woman, really, she's just a floating speck of light the size of a marble. Her name is Umi, which stands for Ugly Manifested Interface, or something like that."

"**Unified Management Interface.**" Umi immediately corrected him. "**Do not misrepresent my designation again or I will force a punishment quest on you.**"

Timothy flinched. She could DO that??

He decided not to test the waters. She had already told him she couldn't influence his quests, but there was no reason to push boundaries unnecessarily.

"Ahaha, I messed up her name." Timothy said with a forced laugh. "It's Unified Management Interface. Because she manages the System."

"Ohh, I see." Marigold said. "I wish I could see your vid-eyeo game power. I am so very confused by it..."

Timothy looked at her. He hesitated. For a brief moment, he felt the urge to invite Marigold to become a Player.

But that wasn't a great idea. At this point, they'd had the equivalent of a one-night stand. It would be better to wait and see how their relationship progressed before he spoke of such an idea. She wasn't his long-time best friend, after all.

"I'll see if I can tweak any options to make that possible." Timothy suggested. "There's a lot of them, though. You might have to wait a while. Anyway! Let's see what each reward offers me."

Timothy stashed his full heal reward since he didn't need it. He opened his second reward, which popped up a lootbox-like interface that was only a little different from before.

Plummet-Guard Boots: [Item] [Common] [Foot Slot] [Utility/Defense]

A pair of reinforced boots fitted with micro-grav crystals and inertial dampeners. When the wearer begins to fall, the boots attempt to activate their stabilizer fields and negate all fall damage (100% reduction) according to the height fallen.

Activation Chance: (11 – stories fallen) × 10%

• 1-story fall: 100% chance

• 3-story fall: 80% chance

• 5-story fall: 60% chance

• 9-story fall: 20% chance

• 10-story fall: 10% chance

If the wearer falls from more than 10 stories, the boots' systems overload and provide no protection.

* * *

Pulseguard Bracers: [Item] [Common] [Arm Slot] [Support/Defense]

Lightweight bracers etched with circuit-like lines that faintly pulse when struck. They grant a reactive 20% chance to reflect a melee attack, redirecting it back at the original attacker. This effect can occur once every 30 seconds.

* * *

Striver’s Collar: [Item] [Common] [Neck Slot] [Support/Enhancement]

A simple collar of interwoven steel and copper that hums faintly when the Player exerts themselves. Whenever the Player performs at least 10 minutes of sustained physical training (combat drills, sprinting, weightlifting, parkour, etc.), the Collar grants a 10% bonus to all physical-stat gains (Strength, Agility, Endurance) earned during that session. The bonus applies once per 24-hour period and resets after the Player completes a full night’s rest. The effect cannot stack with other active “training gain” bonuses and will not trigger if the Player is merely walking or performing mundane tasks.

Timothy eyeballed the three items on offer. They were all common, but they weren't bad. He couldn't help but notice that two of them directly focused on recent problems he had encountered, namely making his exercise more effective and saving him if he fell while scaling a building.

His mother would definitely demand he pick the Plummet-Guard Boots, but Timothy wasn't interested. They were only Common, and the activation chance seemed unreliable. The Pulseguard Bracers seemed equally problematic. He couldn't rely on them to safeguard his life.

Thus, he decided the Striver's Collar was his best option. Whenever he trained with Ferral or Marigold, he'd make much greater gains, and thus speed up his future progress! This was the time to invest in growth opportunities, not choose quick benefits.

Timothy didn't hesitate. He picked the Striver's Collar, then smiled at Marigold as he equipped it. Immediately, a sweatband-like collar appeared around his throat. It was colored black with gold trim along the time. It looked simple, but didn't go with his outfit at all.

Marigold blinked. "Ah... ahaha! What is that silly neck thing?"

"It's called the Striver's Collar." Timothy said, then he explained its purpose.

"Ohhh! So when we go swimming, you will grow stronger even faster. What a smart choice! Too bad it looks silly, kyargh! But I guess your vid-eyeo game won't necessarily have fashion sense!"

Timothy laughed. He chose the third option, and immediately picked Eye of Yredelemnul to improve for his first skill. After putting some thought into his other skills, he chose the Player's Mind ability. He hadn't used it yet, but changing his mental state seemed like it could be extremely beneficial.

Eye of Yredelemnul (Level 2) [MP Cost 0] [AP Cost 0] [Cooldown 0]

The stolen power of a dark god courses through the Player. The Player can examine objects and entities with the Eye of Yredelemnul to learn more information about them. As the Player strengthens, the information available to them will improve drastically.

Improved: The Eye can now see the basic stats of other entities.

Timothy nearly leaped for joy! It only took one improvement, but he'd finally made the Eye useful! Without hesitation, he looked at Marigold and activated the Eye.

Marigold - Crocodile/Chrona

Non-Player | Bottom Mortal

HP 100/100

AP 2/2 | MP 0/0

STR 12 | DEX 11

INT 11 | WIS 8

DEF 12 | RES 8

CHA 13 | LUK 12

Resistances: Blunt: 20%. Piercing: 35%. Heat: 14%.

Weaknesses: Cold: 75%.

Active Skills: Amphibious Swimmer, Agile Climber, Seduce

Passive Skills: Natural Strength, Reptilian Hide

Timothy looked at his own stats and found they had changed a little, but still didn't tell him much. With a thought, he looked up at the trees and spotted a bird chirping. He examined it.

The he looked for the mature crocodile who was overseeing the swimming hole. He examined her stats too.

He decided to collect more data on lots of weak and strong life-forms before making any further decisions regarding his own stats.

Then, Timothy looked at his Player's Mind skill. All its core Mind abilities had slightly improved, but what was more notable was that he had a new mental ability.

Player's Mind (Level 2) (Toggle): [Passive] [Global] [Cooldown 24 Hours]

The Player is able to toggle between various mental states at will, which will enter cooldown after swapping mental states. Mental states offer different positive and negative effects that will vary depending on which states the Player has acquired. More states can be acquired from various sources, including leveling up and quest rewards.

Current mental states available:

Mind of Simplicity: [CURRENTLY SELECTED] 25% resistance to negative mental ailments, such as Fear and Anxiety. No personality changes.

Mind of Focus: Thinking speed decreased by 45%. Mental focus increased 210%. CHA reduced by 45%. INT and WIS increased by 55%. Personality altered to RESEARCHER.

Mind of Void: Immunity to telepathic intrusion. Telepathic attacks reflected back at attacker at 110% damage. Distracting thoughts can be silenced for thirty minute intervals at the cost of 0.9 MP/Min. Personality altered to PSIOPHOBIC.

Mind of Logic: Player's emotions reduced by 95%. Player's thinking speed increased by 100%. Player becomes more adept at solving complex problems, but at the cost of maintaining social relationships. Personality altered to ENGINEER.

Timothy nodded approvingly. The new mental state looked interesting, and it could help him solve tough problems in the future. He'd have to be careful not to enter it

around other people, though. He wouldn't want to act like an even bigger weirdo than he already was. The improvements to his starting mental states were the cherry on top. He hadn't used any of them yet, but they definitely held great promise.

Now, it was time to choose a stat bonus. Timothy activated the final reward, and a new selection popped up.

Improved Body: Your STR and Con improve by 10%.

Improved Control: Your DEX and INT improve by 10%.

Rainbow: All core stats improve by 5%.

Timothy scratched his head. He didn't know how he wanted to specialize in the future, or if he did at all. But simultaneously, he didn't know what a 5% or 10% improvement entailed. How much stronger would he feel?

Timothy strongly considered the rainbow option. But after remembering all his physical struggles in recent days, he opted to pick Improved Body. The selection vanished, and he faintly felt like his muscles had become a little more prominent. He couldn't entirely be sure.

Timothy looked down. He didn't seem to have spontaneously sprouted a six-pack. If he was stronger, he couldn't tell exactly by how much.

The young man shrugged. He touched his new Collar and thought carefully about his gains.

I've improved my body's strength, obtained an item that will boost my exercise gains, and even picked up a couple improvements to my mind and Yredelemnul's Eye. If this is what a single level-up will do, how about five level ups? Ten? A hundred?

He momentarily daydreamed of himself smashing aside Demon Emperors with a single swing of his fist, or firing psychic lasers from the heavens that pierced their bodies and left them dead in their footprints.

Silly, childish fantasies. But fun, nonetheless!

"Okay!" Timothy said, smiling eagerly at Marigold. "I think I'm gonna need your help for this part. I obtained two Aquatic Lootboxes, which are going to have lots of useful

items related to the water. You wanna help me pick which one I keep?"

Marigold nodded. "Oh yes! That sounds like fun! But... I can't see anything you're doing. How will I know what to choose?"

"I'll read all the options off." Timothy said. He grabbed a stick and readied himself to write the details down in the mud. If he had brought a pen and paper, this next part would be a lot easier.

Timothy opened the first Aquatic Lootbox without hesitation. It flashed with light, hummed with energy, and then spit out three windows, which he proceeded to read off to Marigold.

Water Breathing Orb: [Item] [Common] [Accessory] [Support/Growth]

An equippable item that allows the Player to hold their breath for 100% longer underwater. For every 250 hours the Player spends swimming, this effect will improve by another +100% without limit. Note that this expands the Player's innate ability to hold their breath, so Players with stronger lungs will outlast Players with weaker lungs.

Crocodile Form: [Active Skill] [Rare] [Transformation] [Holistic] [100 Mana (Sustained) OR 10 AP (Activated)] [No Cooldown]

The Player gains the ability to transform into a half-crocodile, gaining all the upsides and downsides that come along with such a transformation. Their skin will become hardened and scaled, granting bolstered defense. Their muscles will increase in density. They become incredibly adept in water. However, their mind will slow down somewhat. The player can revert back to their original form for free at any time.

Grants +50% STR, DEX, CON, and HP, with doubled improvements when in water. Grants -50% INT and WIS.

Poseidon's Trident: [Item] [Common] [2H Spear] [Offense/Growth]

Fragment of a weapon once wielded by an ancient Titan King. Possesses a minor ability to command the seas. The Player can bend water around them, with the ability increasing in effect as they accumulate kills when wielding the weapon. The weapon starts out as Common, but can grow all the way to the tier of Mythic.

After explaining all the different options, Timothy and Marigold sat in utter silence. An entire minute passed. Marigold looked at him, then looked away.

"The Crocodile Form..."

"It sounds amazing." Timothy immediately said. "But... it costs 100 Mana or 10 AP to activate. I don't have *either* of those. This Form won't be any use to me for now, and possibly not for a long time."

"But it's a Rare skill." Marigold pointed out. "Isn't that good?"

"Absolutely. If I pick this, and level up several more times, it might be incredibly strong." Timothy said. "But right now, I'd rather think of the other two options. The Water Breathing Orb has a growth component, just like Poseidon's Trident. The only problem is, it needs me to swim a LOT before I can truly make good use of it. For that reason, I think the Trident is the best option here. It just sounds practical, useful, and like it will scale over time to meet my needs."

Marigold seemed unconvinced. "But... but becoming a Crocodile would be great..."

Timothy chewed his lower lip. Even if he wasn't interested in dating Marigold, the Crocodile Form was highly desirable. Being able to power up his body at a moment's notice sounded like a dream. Crocodiles were cool, they looked badass, and it could also serve as a sort of disguise in a pinch.

There's just one problem. Timothy thought. *So far, most of my picks have been focused on improving my body. Generalizing my build is always a bad idea in an RPG. A hybrid mage/brawler will usually lose to a focused mage or brawler. It's best that I focus on my physical body for now. Right?*

Timothy thought of something. He spoke out loud. "Umi, how can I acquire mana?"

Umi materialized near his shoulder.

"**The Quest system will periodically offer Quests to empower your magical abilities, provided you desire to train in that direction. Additionally, some equipment will grant INT, WIS, and mana bonuses. Finally, you may improve your mana and AP stats during certain level ups.**"

"What is AP anyway? Action Points?" Timothy continued.

"**Affirmative. Action Points will be easier for you to acquire as you are presently pursuing a physical build. However, do not forget that you are only**

level 1. You have plenty of time to adjust your future strength. Additionally, other options will become available to you as you level up that can solve your... dilemma."

Timothy raised an eyebrow. "What options?"

"**That information is restricted until you have reached an appropriate level.**" Umi replied.

Timothy rolled his eyes. He waved his hand and sent her away.

Minutes passed. He decided to follow his heart, and chose the Crocodile Form.

"Yay!!" Marigold chirped. "I know you can't use it now, but I hope that when you can, I'll get to see it in action!"

"Of course!" Timothy replied. "Making you happy was at least half the reason I picked it."

In truth, it was Timothy's number one option, mainly because of the raw power it offered. He couldn't use it now, but it would add a huge spike in strength to his character stats when the time was right.

Timothy inhaled. He opened the second Aquatic Lootbox and prepared to read off its contents to Marigold.

"Hopefully, this time we'll get something more immediately useable." Timothy muttered.

Bubble Skin: [Item] [Uncommon] [Body] [Utility]

A fragile bubble the Player can equip to surround their entire body. Allows for infinite breathing underwater, 200% aquatic traversal speed, 100% resistance to underwater pressure at any depth, and the ability to see even in the deepest, darkest oceans. However, any internal or external damage inflicted to the bubble will immediately burst it, leaving the Player to fend for themselves. The Bubble will require 24 hours to repair itself, at which point it will be useable again.

Water Cannon: [Active Skill] [Uncommon] [Offense] [Chargeable] [3 Mana] [5 second cooldown]

The Player gains the ability to fire a highly pressurized bolt of water from their palm. They can charge the attack for up to five seconds, increasing its speed, penetration power, and damage by up to 500%. The mana cost will also rise accordingly.

Octopus Armor [Item] [Uncommon] [Torso] [Balanced]

A versatile set of armor that grants the Player the ability to camouflage themselves when underwater, blending in with their surroundings. When camouflaged, the Player effectively doubles their remaining oxygen, but cannot move. The Player also passively heals 1% of their Max HP every minute underwater when wearing this armor.

Comes with Active Skill: **Octopus Form** [Active Skill] [Uncommon] [Transformation] [Offense] [10 Mana (Sustained) OR 1 AP (Activated)] [No Cooldown]

Octopus Form sprouts six tentacles out of the Player's back. It allows the user to wield multiple additional weapons, up to six 1H weapons or three 2H weapons, in addition to the Player's base two limbs. The Octopus Tentacles cannot be controlled by the player and are fully automated. The player can revert back to their original form for free at any time.

Another grueling choice. Timothy already had the Crocodile Form. Did he really need an Octopus Form too?

"Umi, can the Octopus Form and Crocodile Form be combined?" He asked.

Umi winked into existence.

"**Negative. All Forms are exclusive.**"

Without waiting to be dismissed, Umi vanished. Timothy thought to himself that she seemed a little annoyed with him. Was that possible? Could AIs become annoyed?

He frowned and shook his head, then looked at Marigold.

"Thoughts?"

She shrugged. "The Bubble Skin seems good, but I don't like it. Imagine going deep underwater but then a fish pokes the bubble and it breaks. Kyargh, you'd die! That's way too scary."

"As for the Water Cannon, it seems pretty good." Marigold astutely observed. "I think it would be cool if I could fire bullets out of my palm! Pew-pew!!"

Timothy nodded. He thought for a while.

"It has to be the Octopus Armor. The biggest reason to pick it is for the passive healing. I haven't seen many ways of healing myself, but being able to dive into a pool of water and heal back to full in a couple of hours is really useful. The other effects are equally nice, allowing me to evade pursuers and stealth my body. I wish I could choose all three options, but the Octopus Armor calls out to me. PLUS, I can actually use it right now!"

Timothy made his choice. The Octopus Armor appeared on the ground in front of him, and he equipped it with a single thought.

A sleek, slimy, jelly-like armor formed around his body. Immediately, he found it somewhat gross, and Marigold didn't like it either.

"Eww. That looks weird." Marigold complained. "Kyargh! You won't win any beauty competitions wearing that thing!"

Timothy stood up. He looked himself up and down, then shrugged.

"As long as it works. Marigold, you stay here for a minute. I'm gonna go dive in and hide myself. Try and find me. Let's see how the stealth works on this armor."

Timothy stripped off his clothes, donned the armor, and jogged into the water. He looked comical. With his bare ass, arms, and legs sticking out of the ugly jelly-armor around his torso, he looked like a total doofus.

Timothy dove underwater. He held his breath, and quickly swam down into the abyss. Once he knew he was out of Marigold's sight, he went left, clung to the wall, and found a small nook. He tucked himself in, then mentally activated the Octopus Armor's stealth.

Marigold dove in not long afterward. Her keen eyes allowed her to look left and right, searching for Timothy in the darkness. The young man watched her from below, silently snickering to himself. Even with her trained eyes, Marigold couldn't see him at all!

But then, a situation occurred. Timothy started to run out of air.

He was only twenty feet underwater, but he realized too late that the Octopus Armor only slowed down his breathing. That meant if he could hold his breath for four minutes,

but he spent three minutes swimming to a location, he could extend the remaining duration from one minute to two... but that wasn't enough time to get back to the surface!

SHIT! Timothy exclaimed in his head.

He quickly deactivated his Camouflage, making Marigold easily spot him. She silently laughed, thinking this was part of a game. But then she saw Timothy crazily flailing his limbs as he tried to make it back to the surface.

He was sinking! He couldn't make it back to the top!

Once he was in the underwater abyss, it actually became easier for him to sink than to float.

Timothy's eyes bulged. Panic set in, and he flailed even more crazily, bubbles escaping his lips as he started to feel groggy.

No! No! God not like this! Nooo!

Timothy's eyes stung as he saw the surface of the water slowly growing more and more distant.

His vision turned hazy. Then it turned black...

Marigold swam quickly. She dove down to Timothy, grabbed his arm, and tugged him back up to the surface. They broke to the surface and Marigold lifted Timothy's head out of the water.

Slightly panicked, Marigold turned to the adult crocodile up in the tree.

"H-help!! Timothy's drowning! Help us!!"

That was the last thing Timothy heard before he fell unconscious.

Part 685: Clarity of Mind

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy awoke inside the primary hospital inside Chrona. His head only swam for a few moments before he fully woke up. Then he felt fine.

He sat up in bed and looked around, finding himself in a small hospital room. His bed was both comfortable and sterile. The walls were painted white, and there was a small bench against the opposite wall for guests to sit. A window outside let in a little light, but since Chrona had no sun, it wasn't as if daylight could stream inside.

"You're finally awake." Fiona said. Timothy turned his head to see his mother leaning against the wall beside his bed. She wasn't angry, or sad, or much of anything else. Her expression was eerily... blank.

"Mom..." Timothy said, remembering what had happened. He lowered his eyes. "Sorry."

"At least you're alive." Fiona said coldly. "You really can't keep a promise, can you? You told me you'd be more careful, but then, in your infinite wisdom, you went diving into the abyss without any backup. You didn't even ask the lifeguard to keep an eye out. If Marigold hadn't been there to save you, you would have died."

Timothy swallowed heavily. Every word his mother said was true. He had no retort.

"I'm sorry." Timothy repeated, his tone lame.

"I don't even know how to feel anymore." Fiona said, crossing her arms. "Tears don't work. Anger doesn't work. Nothing I do convinces you to act with greater prudence. What changed? Why did you go from a reclusive young man to a thrill-seeking daredevil? Is your power so coercive that it turns you into an idiot?"

Timothy stared at the far wall. He wasn't sure if he could come up with an answer on the spot.

But he tried.

"I don't know how to put it into words." Timothy muttered. "My whole life... I've felt... not good enough. My dad was a legend. Everyone revered him. Then there's me. A game-obsessed loser. I just sat in my room, doing nothing, wasting away hours, days, weeks,

months, even years. Now, I can turn my hobby into something incredible. I don't know. Maybe I've always been this way, but I just had no mechanism to realize my desires."

Fiona pursed her lips. She looked away and shook her head.

"I made a promise to myself, after your father died." Fiona said. "I promised I would protect you. Let you live a life of easy comfort. It wasn't your responsibility to take on the burden of saving humanity. Your father tried... and he failed."

"He failed?" Timothy repeated. "But I thought he set up a bunch of measures in the event of his death? Wouldn't they...?"

"Maiura fell, and Tarus II was destroyed in the same week. Then he died afterward." Fiona said. "The remaining countermeasures aren't much to speak of. Our best prayer is that removing humanity's Flaw would uplift some humans. So far, from what I've been able to observe, nobody has been Uplifted yet. Even if they were, what could a handful of Lowborn do in the face of Demon Emperors and Deities?"

Fiona plunked down in a chair beside Timothy's bed. Her head lolled back, and she looked up at the ceiling tiredly.

"Why do you want to be humanity's savior, Timothy? Why do you want to keep throwing your life into peril? Just because you feel the need to match up to your father's image? Because you think everyone will mock you behind your back if you don't?"

Timothy shook his head. "Mom, I just-"

"Don't tell me. I don't feel like I can trust anything you say, lately." Fiona said, cutting him off. "Think about it yourself. Think about what sort of man you want to be. You're still young. You're inexperienced, but you obviously have potential. Sit there in that bed for the rest of today... and you think about what you really want out of life."

Fiona turned her head to look at Timothy. She stared for a few long seconds, then heaved a sigh, stood up, and shuffled over to the door.

"I know what you and Marigold were up to. She confessed to me when she brought you in. Casual sex is something you need to be really careful with. As a Trueborn-"

"Mom!" Timothy exclaimed, wanting to crawl out of his skin and die. "She told you?!"

"...As a Trueborn, you are *extremely* good at passing on your genetics." Fiona continued, ignoring her son's interruption. "Your father got your mother pregnant on their first try. Reports have been popping up of humans impregnating non-humans

rapidly across human-space. If Marigold does end up with child, how do you plan to deal with raising a baby while also pursuing your goals? Can you answer that?"

Timothy hesitated. He couldn't believe Marigold would tell his mom something so personal, but now that she had, he couldn't sidestep the problem.

"I..."

"Once again, don't tell me. Talk to yourself. Don't leave this room until you have an answer." Fiona concluded.

She smiled at Timothy, but the expression lacked vitality. She shuffled out of the room and closed the door, leaving Timothy alone.

* * *

Minutes passed. A full hour.

Timothy laid back in bed. He stared up at the ceiling, thinking about a great many things.

"I don't want to be a nobody." Timothy muttered. "I spent seventeen years wasting away in a room. So what if I'm acting a little recklessly now? Maybe I always had this in me. Maybe this is who I really am. The System is only reacting to my desires, right? Then this is what I want. I want to be someone. Accomplish *something*."

Timothy called up his Character page. He looked at the skills that were present.

After a minute, he glanced at the Mental States he had unlocked. He hadn't considered switching to them before, but for some reason, they seemed... oddly appealing right about now.

"Mom told me to stay in the room. I don't think anybody's going to bother me. Maybe I should see if a change of perspective will clear my head."

Timothy's eyes flicked over the newest unlock.

Mind of Logic: Player's emotions reduced by 95%. Player's thinking speed increased by 100%. Player becomes more adept at solving complex problems, but at the cost of maintaining social relationships. Personality altered to ENGINEER.

After hesitating for a moment, Timothy activated the skill. Immediately, a 24 hour cooldown timer began. He could not switch out of the mental state for the rest of the day.

Timothy blinked. He felt the world around him... changing. Or rather, his perception of it.

He looked at the windows and walls. He noticed their architecture. He noticed how they were built, their construction style, their imperfections, and their failings over time. This hospital was over two hundred years old. A lot of time had passed since it was built, and it seemed to be slowly decaying. Another 50 years and there might be a serious structural collapse.

"Now, this is an interesting way of thinking." Timothy said, his voice toneless. He sat up in bed, then he stepped off it to walk over to a nearby table which held some notes on a clipboard the nurse had written. He glanced at the top paper listing details about his condition, then he pulled it off and set it aside.

He wanted a notepad and a pen. He found both.

Timothy walked back over to the bed and sat down cross-legged. He found that without emotions clouding his judgment, he was suddenly able to think with much greater clarity than before.

"Acquire power. Power is the base of everything." Timothy said to himself. He jotted down a note. "I understand why I've always felt helpless. It was because I was suffering from depression. But I am not, now. I am feeling... fine. I understand what must come next."

He wrote down some more notes. Then he looked at his Inventory. He examined his recently acquired skills, items, and other boons. He looked at his Quest page, which showed two days worth of 'Training with Ferral' that he had completed, but not yet claimed. They granted no EXP rewards, but they did grant him three Tier 1 Lootboxes each time the training session ended.

"Sloppy. I should have opened these sooner. Or perhaps not. I am in a better state of mind to open them now. I can more neutrally assess their benefits and demerits without someone else influencing my opinion."

Timothy opened the first of six Lootboxes. Even with his emotions dialed down, he was surprised to see that the rewards it offered were much worse than the other Tier 1 Lootbox he had opened.

Kitchen Knife: [Item] [Mundane] [1H Weapon] [Offense]

A common kitchen implement. Can be used to dice vegetables and slice through meat. Poor durability when used in combat.

Lump of Iron (10kg): [Item] [Mundane] [Material] [Crafting]

A plain lump of iron which can be melted down and reshaped for a variety of purposes. Can also be thrown at an enemy as a makeshift projectile.

Longsword: [Item] [Common] [1H Weapon] [Offense]

An ordinary weapon used by Knights who once lived on ancient Earth. Decent durability. 10% chance to parry an enemy's attack.

Timothy narrowed his eyes. "Strange. These rewards are not nearly as good as the previous ones."

Still, he chose the Longsword. It was basic, but it was better than nothing. Then he opened another Lootbox.

Knee Pads: [Item] [Mundane] [Knees] [Defense/Utility]

These knee pads offer minor protection for a Player's knees. Most useful when kneeling down and crawling into narrow spaces.

Dandelion Seeds x400: [Item] [Junk] [Farming] [Aesthetic]

Seeds which will allow a Player to plant a relatively common weed from ancient Earth. These seeds offer no nutritional value and cannot be used for cooking. Edible only by certain types of insects and herbivore animals.

Gas Mask: [Item] [Common] [Face] [Defense/Utility]

A simple gas mask, useful for filtering out contaminants in the air. Does not include the required oxygen tank and tubes, so it lacks utility without them.

These three items were even worse. Timothy frowned.

"Umi, why are my Lootbox rewards so abysmal? Could it be because I have altered my mental state?"

Umi manifested before him. "**Incorrect. Tier 1 Lootboxes are supposed to contain mostly poor-quality items. Your first Lootbox was extra lucky as a result of the King Network's backend incentive structures. In order to regularly obtain rewards on par with your first Lootbox, you should aim to acquire Tier 2 and 3 Lootboxes instead.**"

"I see." Timothy said simply. "And am I correct in assuming the Aquatic Lootbox offered much greater rewards than usual because it was not locked to a specific tier?"

"**Affirmative.**" Umi replied. "**If a Lootbox does not state a tier, it is 'unlocked' and can roll a higher variance of item qualities.**"

Timothy nodded. He dismissed Umi, then touched his chin.

"I was too eager and foolish. The Crocodile Form is of no use to me right now. If I had been thinking more clearly, I would have used my Rerolls on the Aquatic Lootbox in the hopes of acquiring a much more powerful item, or at least something better suited to my circumstances. I suppose the rewards I chose were not bad, all things considered."

Timothy started to enjoy himself a little bit. He had never felt this focused and alert. It felt as if he had become an entirely different person. True, his emotions had been dulled to the point of irrelevance, but he still experienced enjoyment of the small things. Only now, what he enjoyed was creating a plan and executing it excellently.

He also really wanted to construct something. He felt this was his biggest yearning. Perhaps it was because he had assumed the mental state of an engineer...

Timothy opened another Lootbox. He selected one of the three items inside, which turned out to be fifty kilograms of steel.

"This item seems to be for a 'crafting' system which I currently do not possess. Perhaps I will unlock it in the future. However, Chrona is lacking in certain materials. Could farming Lootboxes be another way to acquire these resources? Thinking only of my own needs is rather short-sighted. Even if I cannot make use of something, someone else in Chrona might."

He opened another Lootbox, the fourth of six. There, the options were a little surprising.

Hermes' Sneakers: [Item] [Uncommon] [Feet] [Defense/Utility]

When equipped, these shoes will increase the Player's running speed by up to 25%, and their agility when turning corners by another 25%. Stamina usage while running is also reduced by 10%. Provides minimal defense to the Player's feet.

Affection Assessor: [Item] [Uncommon] [Accessory] [Utility]

Allows the Player to determine the Affection Level of other entities. Entities can be assessed in relation to one another, and in relation to the Player. Assesses multiple metrics of affection at once. Can be used repeatedly at no cost and with no cooldown.

Strange Spoon: [Item] [Junk] [Utility]

A spoon which can be bent and twisted around at the Player's mental command. Useful only as a fun party trick.

Getting two Uncommon items at once was quite interesting. Timothy obviously ignored the spoon, but he weighed the pros and cons of choosing the Sneakers or the Assessor.

"Earlier, I was unable to obtain bonus rewards for the Swimming With Marigold quest. This was because I failed to increase her Affection beyond a certain level. Having the Affection Assessor would improve my ability to complete similar quests in the future. But in terms of steady usefulness, the Hermes' Sneakers are much more valuable."

Timothy thought for a while. The Sneakers, he decided, were good, but he was likely to get similar items in the future. The Affection Assessor gave him a unique ability that he could not only use for his own ends, but for others as well. He could determine the relationship levels between different Sentients with ease.

This seemed minor. But in reality, it could grant him crucial insights in strategic information warfare in the future. Knowing who hated and who loved who was a big deal in geopolitical relations.

With that, Timothy opened up the last two Lootboxes.

...He wasn't impressed by what he found, but he still picked two more items he found useful.

Fortifying Belt: [Item] [Common] [Waist] [Healing/Utility]

Improves the Player's disease resistance against common illnesses by 50%. Has no effect if worn after becoming sick. Cannot cure a disease.

Earring Radar: [Item] [Common] [Ears] [Scouting/Utility]

An item which allows the Player to sense movement in a 25-meter radius around themselves. Cannot differentiate between movement above or below. Cannot differentiate between friend and foe.

After selecting those two items, Timothy was done. He had no further Lootboxes remaining, and was fairly satisfied, even considering the poor offerings on display.

Timothy picked up the clipboard once again. He scrawled down some notes, then started to think once more.

"This mental state is quite satisfactory. I am able to think clearly, without prejudice, and without emotions clouding my judgment. Perhaps I should leave this as my default mental state. It feels much better than being a whiny brat who can't make up his mind and who disappoints everyone."

Unfortunately, he knew his mother would easily notice his massive personality shift. She would freak out, start yelling again…

How troublesome.

Her constant nagging was somewhat irritating. He was an adult now. He didn't need to listen to her lectures. It was time he started making his own mark on the world.

Timothy looked out the window.

"Well, she said I should stay in here until I made a decision. Looks like I've done just that. No sense sitting around, accomplishing nothing. I need to acquire more Quest rewards."

Timothy opened his Quests again. He observed that after his raucous lovemaking session with Marigold, he had completed four of six objectives in her primary quest.

[Story Quest] Timothy, SMASH!

Marigold is your type. She's totally into you, just look at the way she's batting her eyes! You should quickly seduce her and take her to a private room. Gain additional rewards for each romance stage you progress!

First Base Rewards: [CHA Improved by 5%], [DEX Improved by 5%] **(COMPLETE!)**

Second Base Rewards: [CHA Improved 5%], [DEX Improved by 5%] **(COMPLETE!)**

Third Base Rewards: [Heat Resistance +10%], [Cold Resistance +10%] **(COMPLETE!)**

Fourth Base Rewards: [STA Improved 10%], [STR Improved 10%] **(COMPLETE!)**

Obtain Girlfriend: [Respect+] [Currency Gain +10%] [Experience Gain +10% (Permanent)]

Obtain Marriage: [STA Improved +50%], [Skill: Mental Resilience]

Note: All benefits except Permanent buffs will disappear if the relationship ends under negative terms.

Timothy had not yet accepted the rewards. He immediately did so. At once, his body subtly changed in a way he couldn't comprehend. He felt a little different, but the difference was subtle enough that he couldn't mentally quantify it.

His DEX and CHA had both shot up by 10%. He had more Heat and Cold Resistance. His STA and STR had also gone up by 10%. But how much was 10%, anyway?

Timothy thought about it for a minute. 10% didn't seem like much, but he had basically improved his entire body by a holistic 10%.

Ten percent was the difference between a 6' individual and a 6'6" individual. It was the difference between lifting 200lbs versus lifting 220lbs. It was the difference between running 5 MPH and 5.5 MPH.

The only question was...

"Umi, when I obtain stat gains, do they compound on top of my existing stats, or do they add to a baseline of some sort?"

Umi replied without manifesting. "**Stat gains compound on top of your existing body.**"

This was a massive revelation. Timothy instantly realized that he was drastically underestimating the value of stats.

Compounding gains were small and low impact... until they weren't. Once they reached a certain level, they would quickly spiral out of control.

This was why compound interest was extremely important when saving and investing money on ancient Earth. It was also why compound interest with personal debt was so destructive.

"The System giveth, and the System taketh away." Timothy said to himself.

He climbed off the bed, then dropped to the floor and pressed his palms against the cold white tiles. He began doing pushups, one after the other.

At once, a Quest appeared.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Train Your Body!

Small gains compound over time. Perform a series of exercises, with increasing rewards depending on how many repetitions you can complete. To complete this Quest properly, you must complete each type of exercise in one session each. You may not space them out across the day, or across multiple days.

[Complete Pushups: 3/100.] Rewards: 1x Tier 1 Lootbox.

[Complete Pullups: 0/100.] Rewards: 1x EXP per 3 Pullups. 100th Pullup grants 5 EXP.

[Complete Situps: 0/100.] Rewards: +2.5% END, +2.5% CON.

[Complete Squats: 0/100.] Rewards: 1x Mundane Skill Lootbox.

[Complete A Nonstop Jog: 0/10 Km.] Rewards: +5% maximum movement speed.

[Eat Cooked Meat: 0/1.5 Kilograms.] Rewards: +2.5% Gut Digestion.

[Eat Vegetables: 0/1.5 Kilograms.] Rewards: +2.5% Eyesight Improvement.

Note: If the Player completes all Quest objectives within 24 hours, all rewards will be doubled. This Quest may be completed once per 24 hour period.

Timothy paused his pushups. But only for a few moments. He scanned the Quest's contents, then nodded.

"As expected. The System reacted to my actions. I have been entirely too passive in how I pursued Quests. This oversight will not continue any longer."

And so, he began to work on his body, only pausing to call in a nurse and ask her to prepare him an extremely large and nutritious meal.

His journey of self improvement had truly begun. Later, he would be sure to make his relationship with Marigold official in order to obtain that permanent EXP boost.

Part 686: Maximizing Gains

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy worked hard. He grinded out 100 pushups in one sitting, which took him around thirty minutes. After resting for five minutes, he switched to crunches. Those only took him fifteen minutes. Then, he switched to situps, which were effectively much more tiring forms of crunches.

He finally hit a wall. It took him nearly forty-five minutes to finish, and he was so exhausted he needed a serious break. Luckily, the food the nurse had brought him was sitting on a table, cold but edible. Timothy grabbed the massive plate of meat and veggies, wolfing around a third of it down before he felt stuffed. He burped, then frowned. He had seriously underestimated just how much food the System required him to devour.

By this point, he had spent two entire hours exercising and eating, and the food wasn't even close to finished.

Timothy sat on the floor and laid back against the wall. He became contemplative.

"This exercising quest is troublesome. I can repeat it daily, and it will give me great gains. But it requires a lot of time. Time is a precious resource. Is exercising truly the best way to spend such a limited resource?"

Timothy opened up his Quests. He looked at his three repeatable quests specifically.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Training With Ferral.

You and Ferral are both Newbies, but Ferral is a stronger Sentient than you. Train your combat skills with him to increase your capabilities.

Rewards: [3 EXP], 3x Lootbox Tier 1.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Swimming with Marigold

It's a date, but it's also training! Go swimming with Marigold, and try to improve your relationship with her while getting in a good workout. Swim for at least one hour, with rewards doubled if you swim for two hours. Rewards can be earned from this quest once per day. If Marigold's affection for you increases past a certain point, other

bonuses can be unlocked. (Note: Informing Marigold of this clause in any way will nullify those bonuses.)

Rewards: [1 EXP Per 5 Minutes spent Swimming], [Stamina Improved 5%]

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Train Your Body!

Small gains compound over time. Perform a series of exercises, with increasing rewards depending on how many repetitions you can complete. To complete this Quest properly, you must complete each type of exercise in one session each. You may not space them out across the day, or across multiple days.

[Complete Pushups: 100/100.] Rewards: 1x Tier 1 Lootbox.

[Complete Pullups: 0/100.] Rewards: 1x EXP per 3 Pullups. 100th Pullup grants 5 EXP.

[Complete Situps: 100/100.] Rewards: +2.5% END, +2.5% CON.

[Complete Squats: 100/100.] Rewards: 1x Mundane Skill Lootbox.

[Complete A Nonstop Jog: 0/10 Km.] Rewards: +5% maximum movement speed.

[Eat Cooked Meat: 0.6/1.5 Kilograms.] Rewards: +2.5% Gut Digestion.

[Eat Vegetables: 0.4/1.5 Kilograms.] Rewards: +2.5% Eyesight Improvement.

Note: If the Player completes all Quest objectives within 24 hours, all rewards will be doubled. This Quest may be completed once per 24 hour period.

As Timothy examined these quests, he thought carefully about time management.

"I am probably able to stay awake for maybe 14 or 16 hours a day at maximum. Fewer if I'm exhausted and require sleep. Looking at the Body Training quest, I've already spent two hours on it, and I must have at least another hour or two to go. That's around 20-30% of an entire day spent training. The good news is, most of these rewards are compounding. The Mundane Skill Lootbox is something I'd rather skip, but then I lose out on doubling all the other rewards."

"Training with Ferral is practically useless in terms of EXP, but it gives me lots of Tier 1 Lootboxes, and it doesn't take much time. Training with him for thirty minutes is enough to meet the quest's requirements."

"Training with Marigold is troublesome. It always requires two full hours to double the rewards, but it offers decent EXP and most importantly, a compounding Stamina gain that will benefit me greatly."

"If I seek to complete all three of these quests every day, I will likely need at least… five hours. Perhaps six."

Timothy's expression shifted. He looked off to the side while his brain spun into action.

"No. That isn't correct. The reason my exercise regimen takes so much time is because I'm out of shape. The more in-shape I become, the faster I can complete it. Since the gains are compounding, there may come a day when I could complete the entire regimen in less than an hour, or perhaps even less than 30 minutes. And don't forget that it also improves my gut digestion, which will let me consume nutrients more quickly."

Timothy analyzed the costs and benefits with almost robotic precision. There was no emotion in his words. Only cold, hard logic.

"The EXP I gain with Marigold is only relevant at these low levels. It doesn't scale at all. The 10% Stamina gain is the real prize… but is it worth spending two hours every day to achieve? I think after three or four more sessions, and another level up or two, I should not bother with that quest anymore. I'm sure Marigold won't mind."

The emotional impact of abandoning their dates after only a few instances didn't matter to Timothy at all. He disregarded her opinion on the matter entirely to focus on his own self-gains.

Timothy's expression suddenly turned ugly.

"Damn! If I had chosen those running shoes, I could have increased my run speed and cut down on the time needed to complete the 10km jog! I'll definitely have to prioritize a similar item in the future."

His flicker of irritation vanished. He had overlooked a key detail, but he would work not to make such a similar mistake in the future. He was a logical thinker now, not an emotional child who blundered along like a fool. That other embarrassing side of himself felt like ancient history. He had zero intention of undoing the Mind of Logic once the 24 hours were up. He intended to remain in this state of mind *permanently*.

Timothy stood up. He had rested enough. He still needed to finish eating the required amount of food, and finish his pullups, and finish a ten kilometer jog.

It was time to leave his hospital room.

He stepped out, then grabbed the crocodile nurse from before, informing her he was going out to exercise. He would return later, finish his food, then be done with the hospital room. Since everyone knew who Timothy was, she instead offered to send his food over to his house so he could go there instead. He agreed.

As soon as Timothy exited the hospital, he paused to activate his Map. He scrutinized Chrona's city structure.

"I still need to do pullups. I haven't trained with Ferral today, either. Maybe I can save some time by combining different training quests? 'Training with Ferral' is rather vague. Perhaps doing pullups with him would count? It's a shame swimming isn't on here, or I could double-dip with Marigold's training..."

Hardly had the thought occurred to Timothy when a new component was added to his exercising quest.

[Swim Session: 0/10 Km.] Rewards: +2.5% swimming speed.

Timothy grimaced. He had already completed his quest with Marigold today, so he wasn't actually going to be able to double-dip like he had planned. Now he had another requirement added onto his physical training quest he had to complete before he could get doubled rewards!

"Oh well. I can get a 5% swimming speed increase, which also compounds like my other gains."

Timothy groaned, but got over himself. He looked at Chrona's map. In the center of the city was the Spynet Sphere. It was the most important part of Chrona, and the entire reason Jason had built the place. A block east was Jason's warehouse, which until recently had been abandoned. Timothy's house was two blocks north of the Spynet, with a restaurant in between. The hospital he had been taken to was several blocks west, and the swimming hole was way up north.

Down south was where the Psions had been placed. There weren't many of them, and they couldn't reproduce. Thus, their living was fixed, and they didn't complain anyway.

Psions lived plain lives, enjoying little in the way of furnishings or adornments in their rooms.

The Crocodiles overwhelmingly lived to the west, north, and east, several blocks from the Spynet Sphere. They were reproducing quickly, and thus their housing had to constantly be upgraded, raised, and evolved. In the past, the tallest building in Chrona had been the first hospital, but in recent years it had been dwarfed by giant ten-story residential apartments. Dense housing was essential in an isolated bubble-realm with such little living space.

Trees had been planted around the edges of Chrona, creating a 'forest border' of sorts. These trees provided oxygen, but had to be manually watered, and the solar energy given to them came from Jason's Star-Net, which Fiona had repurposed into energy that powered all of Chrona's essential functions.

The problem was, Jason was always the one who had to open up new links to stars in the outer galaxy. With him gone, and with the time acceleration slowly lowering the amount of power Chrona could drain from stars in realspace, they were sure to face a serious energy crisis in the future. That was, of course, dependent on whether or not Fiona solved the crisis before it happened.

Timothy routed himself to go east, then south, then west, then north. He would conclude his journey at the swimming hole, but would loop around a few times before stopping to see Ferral in the southern Psion district. There, he would hit his tenth kilometer for the run, finish with pullups and training with Ferral, the complete his last remaining task by doing laps at the swimming hole.

As Timothy started to jog, he maintained an expressionless face. He found neither joy nor misery in running. With his emotions locked down, he only did what had to be logically done to accelerate his progress.

He jogged past the Spynet. If his mother was inside, she didn't seem to notice him. He made his way northeast, then looped back down to the southeast before cutting down and around to the south.

I was able to obtain certain rewards by fraternizing with Marigold. Timothy thought idly. *I will lose those benefits if the relationship 'ends badly.' But that implies if the relationship never ends, or if it ends on a good note, I can keep them forever. What if I*

were to find a second partner to hold a relationship with? As long as Marigold never finds out, would I be able to double or triple-dip, obtaining even greater benefits?

A quest didn't pop up, but Timothy believed if he held serious intent to go down this path, a quest would definitely form.

It would be too troublesome. Timothy thought. *Maintaining one relationship is a time-sink already. I would rather find more useful and repeatable ways to empower myself. There must be other forms of daily quests I can complete.*

Ah hour passed. Timothy jogged around Chrona, eventually coming to a stop outside of the Psion habitat. A thought occurred to him as he recalled a recent conversation with Ferral. Timothy opened up his Options menu, and scrolled down to the Party settings. He suddenly realized he had not looked deeply enough into the Options menu, due to its massive list of toggleable and adjustable settings. The old him had been too overwhelmed to bother, but for the *new* him...

"See party member statuses. Check."

Timothy looked to the top left of his vision. A portrait of Ferral had appeared, with his HP and Psion Points listed beside it.

Timothy went back into the Options.

"Party member activity. Check."

Nothing seemed to happen. Timothy checked around further in the settings.

"Enable activity log. Ah, here it is. Check."

After enabling it, a new tab appeared on his side menu. Timothy clicked it and found a whole log of his quests actions, recent accomplishments, and other such things. Not just his, but Ferral's too! The log descended from most recent activity to the least recent...

Ferral Completed Quest: Ring Out!

Timothy Reached Level 1!

Timothy Completed Quest: Swimming with Marigold.

Ferral Completed Quest: Tangle with Tarim.

Ferral Reached Level 2!

Ferral Completed Quest: Training with Timothy.

Timothy Completed Quest: Training with Ferral.

Ferral Completed Quest: Sense 1000 Lifeforms.

Ferral Completed Quest: Meditation At 1 Kilometer

Timothy Completed Quest: Training with Ferral.

Ferral Reached Level 1!

Ferral Completed Quest: Training with Timothy

Timothy Completed Quest: Training with Ferral.

Ferral Completed Quest: Levitate 1000 Small Objects.

Timothy stared at the quest log. If he hadn't been in the Mind of Logic, he would have definitely gasped or felt extreme shock. How was Ferral outpacing him when it came to leveling up, especially when he had a massive EXP penalty? Timothy had just reached Level 1, but Ferral was already at Level 2! And he was way ahead of Timothy, as well!

But Timothy wasn't shocked or alarmed. It made sense. He had been rather lazy and lackadaisical about his growth before activating the Mind of Logic. Ferral, as a logical-minded creature from birth, was also thousands of years old. He had more brainpower to spare on how to best optimize his System growth.

"My friend's growth is my growth." Timothy said out loud. "I am glad for him. He works harder than me, so he should reap the rewards."

Timothy couldn't see what the Quest descriptions were or what the rewards gave, but he could glean a little insight based on their names. Tarim was one of the other Psions. Perhaps Ferral had a rivalry going on with Tarim, or they were doing dual-training, just like how Timothy was training with Ferral and Marigold.

Timothy closed the log. He stepped into the Psion Enclave, where he heard the loud sounds of psionic blasts striking each other. It seemed a battle was happening; standard practice for Chrona's Psions.

When he entered the training room, a heavily reinforced underground bunker with high-level Wordsmithium walls, ceiling, and floors, he felt the shockwaves of two powerful Psions blasting each other.

Timothy stopped as he entered the training area. In the center of the room, the 2nd Level Psion, Dunal, was violently battling against Ferral.

Dunal had chosen to focus on Primal Psionics. He was considered the most powerful of the Psion trainees, mainly because the others were not as combat focused as him. His pure blue skin stood out against Ferral's red-and-blue camouflage-patterned skin.

Ferral was a grab bag of a Psion. He had always had trouble battling against any of the other Psions, because all of them had chosen to specialize and focus on specific disciplines, while Ferral quickly grew bored and wanted to try out a variety of Paths.

This had always been his undoing, but it seemed that was no longer the case. Now, he wielded Primal Psionics at a similar level to his opponent.

Focused psionic blasts impacted Dunal's psionic barrier. He body shook, but he held firm. He rushed around the ring, swooping like a hawk as he fired back at Ferral, who likewise dipped and flipped, evading Dunal's counter-attacks.

Timothy stared, feeling slightly awed. He had seen Ferral fight before, but never like this. The so-called 'weakest psion' had grown his power by leaps and bounds. His fighting style was more clean and focused. He was improving at an alarming rate.

Unfortunately, Ferral slipped up and failed to dodge one of Dunal's attacks. A psionic whip struck his left shoulder, causing his heart to momentarily seize up. That moment of weakness allowed Dunal to swoop over and deliver a downward punch at the back of Ferral's head. He pounded Ferral into the floor and nearly knocked him unconscious.

[Match point. Dunal has won.] Aspirator Raavul, the sole 3rd Level Psion and teacher of their Enclave, said. [Though Ferral has lost, I am not so certain he will lose next time. Dunal! You fought well, but your training speed and efficiency has fallen far below Ferral's. I expect you to perform even better in your next sanctioned match.]

[Yes, Aspirator.] Dunal said, dropping to one knee in the center of the ring and bowing his head toward her. [I contemplate, and I comprehend.]

Ferral groaned. He picked himself up, then dusted his body off. When Timothy checked Ferral's status in the party window, it showed he had only lost three or four percent of his HP. However, these battles were not being fought to the death. They were fought with the goal of scoring crucial hits and earning points. A loss was a loss, and Ferral had failed to overcome his enemy.

[Well fought.] Ferral said, standing up. He bowed respectfully toward Dunal. [My training has not been harsh enough. Next time we duel, I will win.]

[We shall see if that is the case when the time comes.] Dunal said, clapping his fist into his palm as a respectful salute.

After the two split up, Ferral noticed Timothy and flew over to meet him.

[Timothy. I am ashamed you had to witness such a pitiful defeat.]

"Everyone has an off day." Timothy said mildly. "I finally remembered to enable the Party Activity Log. I had not realized you were already at Level Two. Your pace is impressive."

[I prioritize quests that grant experience.] Ferral replied. He cracked his neck, which had been lightly jolted by the impact against the Wordsmithium floor. [Thus, my quests tend not to grant skills or items. I am focused on growing my personal strength as high as possible.]

Timothy pondered Ferral's words. He had been doing things rather haphazardly, accepting any old Quest the System threw his way, doing them, and using up the rewards. Maybe training with Ferral to obtain some crappy Lootboxes wasn't the best use of his time.

Suddenly, an idea sparked in Timothy's mind. He smiled at Ferral.

"Brother Ferral, if I may make a suggestion? Why don't you and I travel to the swimming hole and engage in some bodily training? Let's see who can swim ten kilometers first? That will replace our usual training here. But *no* psionics. This will be purely to enhance our body's strengths."

Ferral contemplated Timothy's suggestion. [This suggestion is agreeable to me. But why do I suspect that you have an ulterior motive?]

The moment Ferral agreed, their shared training quest changed.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Training With Ferral.

An adjusted form of the previous Training Quest. Swim 10 kilometers alongside Ferral. If you succeed in achieving the 10 kilometer objective before him, your rewards

will be doubled. If you swim all 10 kilometers before he has made it to 5 kilometers, your rewards will be tripled.

[Swim Session: 0/10 Km.] Rewards: [5 EXP per kilometer swam], 1x Talent Points.

Timothy's smile became slightly more pronounced. As expected, Quests were not static and could change based on a variety of factors. Just like how he had added new requirements and rewards to his daily training quest, he could do so with Ferral's training quest.

The young human looked at Ferral. "Hey, you know what? Let's add one more thing. Let's also compete to see who can reach 100 pullups first."

Ferral cocked his head. [The purpose being?]

"Trust me. Just agree to it. I'll explain later."

Ferral nodded. [Then this additional body training is acceptable. I must become stronger, faster.]

Just like that, the quest changed again.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Training With Ferral.

An adjusted form of the previous Training Quest. Swim 10 kilometers alongside Ferral. If you succeed in achieving the 10 kilometer objective before him, your rewards will be doubled. If you swim all 10 kilometers before he has made it to 5 kilometers, your rewards will be tripled. Additionally, you have agreed to also compete in pullups. The King Network knows what you are doing.

[Swim Session: 0/10 Km] Rewards: [5 EXP per kilometer swam], 1x Talent Points.

[Complete Pullups: 0/100] Rewards: 1x EXP per 3 Pullups. 100th Pullup grants 5 EXP.

Timothy wanted to crow like a bird. He actually felt real, tangible excitement at the realization he'd figured out a cool way to exploit the System.

Timothy clapped Ferral on the back. "Good. Let's get going, then."

As they started to walk out of the Enclave, Ferral turned to him and frowned.

[You are acting very different from usual. You remind me of a Psion.]

"Really? I'll take that compliment." Timothy answered. "But in truth, I activated a skill which allowed me to alter my mental state, and this was the result..."

Part 687: Pain in the Gut

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Several hours later, Timothy and Ferral finished their last exercise. Timothy found himself humiliated when his Psion friend, even without using Psionics, completely outclassed him in the physicality department.

Not only could Ferral complete 100 pullups much more easily than Timothy, he could also swim faster as well. Timothy really wanted to believe Ferral was cheating, but no. He wasn't.

[I am thousands of cycles old.] Ferral reminded Timothy, as they sat on the grass at the edge of the swimming hole. [I only casually exercise, but I do it constantly. I must keep up with my fellow Psions. I was never nearly as motivated as them, but the King Network has drastically enhanced my training efficiency. I will not be as I once was.]

Timothy glared at the System's reminder.

You have failed to obtain bonuses from Training with Ferral.

He wasn't too mad, though. He still managed to double up on his self-training and his Ferral-training. He was looking forward to accepting all the rewards once he went home and got some sleep.

"Aren't you curious about the new hack I figured out with the System?" Timothy asked Ferral.

[Does it involve manipulating System quests to better fit your training needs?] Ferral retorted.

"What? You knew?" Timothy asked, slightly frowning.

[I have been making use of this exploit myself.] Ferral said. [I posited that was your goal when you asked me to train with you. You must be doubling up on quest rewards.]

Timothy might have felt a bit glum if he wasn't currently using the Mind of Logic. Instead, he simply shrugged his shoulders. "You've always been sharp, Ferral."

A moment of silence fell over the two men. Timothy chugged a bottle of water he'd filled up along their run, while Ferral closed his eyes and meditated to relieve his mild

exhaustion. He was far better off than Timothy, as his endurance was ten times higher at a minimum. Perhaps if Timothy had realized it was futile challenging his best friend, he might not have bothered. Then again, having a rival to challenge was always conducive to one's growth.

[Timothy.] Ferral suddenly said, while still continuing to meditate. [This new 'mental state' you have initiated. I am not certain I like it. You are not acting like yourself.]

Timothy glanced at Ferral's side-profile. "I am in control of my emotions now. I am able to think with clarity and logic... like you. Shouldn't you be glad I am able to mimic a Psion's state of mind? Better than being a wishy-washy loser who constantly blubbers and blunders."

Ferral was not swayed. He opened his eyes and looked at Timothy.

[Just because you are flawed, that does not mean you have no value. I have never perceived you as a 'loser'. If you are a loser, then what am I? I have always been the worst Psion. I train slowly and without enjoyment. I have historically held little passion when it comes to matters of developing my Seed. Even ascending to the 2nd Level took me far longer than my peers. This, in spite of the fact that my genetics come from formidable Psions. In theory, I should outpace all of my peers, but I am always left behind.]

Ferral slowly blinked his eyes.

[I recognize the King Network for what it is. It is a tool I can use to reshape my mentality. I can derive enjoyment from converting my future progression into tangible numbers. I can 'play a game', one which evolves my physical body. But in the end, I only view it as a means to an end. I will not allow it to corrupt Who I Am.]

Ferral reached out and touched Timothy's shoulder.

[You are different. You feel that you are a being of inferior value to other beings. You are using the King Network to compensate for your perceived flaws.]

"But I am flawed. I'm way more flawed than you." Timothy protested.

[I have just told you of my own flaws and challenges, yet you speak such words. You may be more 'logical', but your mental process is still emotional at its core.] Ferral said. [If the King Network disappears tomorrow, I will be sad. I enjoy watching my stats go up. I enjoy the feeling of tangibly improving myself. I enjoy taking one step closer to my

goals, followed by another. But I do not inherently see the King Network as a reflection of my self-worth. You do. And that is the problem.]

Ferral shook his head and closed his eyes.

[You are using the Mental State skill as a crutch. You are forcibly changing the way you think in order to cover up perceived personality flaws. It is fine to use the Mental States as tools to achieve specific objectives, but the way you speak tells me you intend to remain in this Mental State for a very long time. Am I correct?]

Timothy hesitated. Every word Ferral spoke felt like a needle piercing his heart. Even with his emotions dialed down by 95%, he still felt as if he had been wounded.

"I... I did intend to remain in this state. Yes." Timothy finally admitted. "What is wrong with wanting to think clearly? What is wrong with acting and speaking logically instead of constantly screwing up and hurting the people around me? It sure seems to work for you."

Ferral became eerily quiet. He stared off into the distance.

Then he did something weirdly uncharacteristic of a Psion.

He chuckled.

[Heh heh... I see now. You think I am better than you because I was born superior. But you are unaware of the Truths of my life. Multiple Psions joined their Seeds together to create a powerful progeny, and the result was me. I am thousands of years old, yet my Psionic progress has proven vastly inferior to my peers. I was abandoned by my creators. I was a disappointment.]

[How do you think I ended up here?] Ferral concluded. [I was sent to Aspirator Raavul's enclave because she was seen as useless, just like me. I was sent there because I was a failure. Proctor Landis and my other creators gave up on me.]

Timothy blinked. He gave Ferral a strange look. "You... they considered you a failure?"

[If multiple powerful beings combine their power to create a progeny that should eclipse them, but that progeny instead fails to keep up with the slowest learners in his enclave, what else can that progeny be called but a failure?] Ferral posited. [They abandoned me because I lost my value. If you are a loser among humans, than I am even more a loser among Psions.]

Timothy gazed at the ground. He digested Ferral's words carefully.

"So you think I'm better in my... 'natural' state of mind?"

[Emphatically.] Ferral replied. [Because that is the real 'you.' That is the person who I befriended. I have no problem with you temporarily making yourself more logical. I have no problem with you using the tools the King Network gives you to solve problems. But that is what they are, and what they must be. Tools. Do not allow the System to supplant the essence of who you are.]

Timothy nodded. A strange feeling welled up in his body. He realized the 'wisdom' he thought he had acquired through this new State of Mind was false. It might heighten some parts of himself and dull others, but fundamentally they were always there.

He lacked discipline. If he worked to hone his mind as much as he did his body, he could achieve even greater results!

"I still have to wait twenty-four hours before I can transition to a different Mental State." Timothy said. "Thank you, Ferral. When the time comes, I will revert back to my normal self."

[If this current Mental State is helping you be more efficient or solve specific problems, there is no need to change back.] Ferral said softly. [It is only important to me that you do not view your 'normal' self as inferior or lacking in quality. I like my friend just the way he always has been.]

Ferral levitated to his feet. He bowed to Timothy. [I am leaving now. There is still much training ahead of me.]

"Wait." Timothy said, before pulling up his Quests. "Tomorrow, what say we meet at noon? We'll do a lot more training, doubling up on the entries in my daily quest. I'm going to invite Marigold along, too."

[You wish for the female crocodile to join us in our training?] Ferral asked. [Have you granted her access to the King Network? Have you made her a Player?]

Timothy slowly shook his head. "I... have not. The slots are limited. I can only invite two more people. I was thinking of inviting my mom, and Monster King Kar."

[I understand. You are the Administrator. It is your prerogative to invite or not invite new Players. You must take care to choose only those who you can trust, as well.] Ferral said sagely. [But if you are planning to invite Marigold, I believe it would be the height of

selfishness if she obtained no benefits from joining us. Do not treat her as a mere object that will help you complete Quests.]

Timothy looked away. He nodded carefully. "All good points. Thank you for the reminder, Ferral. I'll sleep on it and decide tomorrow."

Ferral tilted his head forward, then flew into the sky. He quickly sped up and rocketed away. Timothy noted that Ferral's flying speed had sharply increased over the last few days. He was improving at a shocking pace.

Timothy looked at his Quests.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Training With Ferral.

An adjusted form of the previous Training Quest. Swim 10 kilometers alongside Ferral. If you succeed in achieving the 10 kilometer objective before him, your rewards will be doubled. If you swim all 10 kilometers before he has made it to 5 kilometers, your rewards will be tripled. Additionally, you have agreed to also compete in pullups. The King Network knows what you are doing.

[Swim Session: 10/10 Km] [5 EXP per kilometer swam], 1x Talent Points.

[Complete Pullups: 100/100] 1x EXP per 3 Pullups. 100th Pullup grants 5 EXP.

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Train Your Body!

Small gains compound over time. Perform a series of exercises, with increasing rewards depending on how many repetitions you can complete. To complete this Quest properly, you must complete each type of exercise in one session each. You may not space them out across the day, or across multiple days.

[Complete Pushups 100/100] Rewards: 1x Tier 1 Lootbox.

[Complete Pullups: 100/100] Rewards: 1x EXP per 3 Pullups. 100th Pullup grants 5 EXP.

[Complete Situps: 100/100] Rewards: +2.5% END, +2.5% CON.

[Complete Squats: 100/100] Rewards: 1x Mundane Skill Lootbox.

[Complete Long Jog: 10/10 Km] Rewards: +5% maximum movement speed.

[Swim Session: 10/10 Km] Rewards: +2.5% swimming speed.

[Eat Cooked Meat: 0.6/1.5 Kgs] Rewards: +2.5% Gut Digestion.

[Eat Vegetables: 0.4/1.5 Kgs] Rewards: +2.5% Eyesight Improvement.

Note: If the Player completes all Quest objectives within 24 hours, all rewards will be doubled. This Quest may be completed once per 24 hour period.

Timothy had fully completed the revised Ferral Quest, but he was going to wait to accept its rewards until after he finished the daily training quest. He failed to beat Ferral in any categories, but the base rewards were already good enough for his short term needs.

Unfortunately, Timothy still needed to finish the hospital's food, which had definitely made it to his house by now. He took off and walked south until he spotted Marigold lingering outside his house. As soon as she saw him, she jumped off the boulder she was sitting on and clapped her claws together.

"Kyargh! Timothy, you're alright! I was so worried! The nurse said to leave you alone, but then I heard you left the hospital early, so I came to your house but you weren't here, so I figured I'd just sit down and wait until you got back!"

She babbled quickly, clearly excited by the fact that Timothy had survived. He seemed to be doing fine, with no ill after-effects.

"Me and Ferral hung out for a while. I spoke to him about several matters and cleared up my thoughts." Timothy said, his face expressionless. "Marigold, thank you for rescuing me. I would have drowned if it wasn't for you."

Marigold's yellow scales momentarily flushed pink. She squeezed her claws together and smiled in that animalistic way only a croc-girl could. "I was there, so obviously I saved you! It's nothing to thank me for! Um, are you doing anything right now?"

Timothy yawned loudly. "I'm actually heading home so I can get some sleep. How would you like to meet up with me and Ferral tomorrow at noon?"

Marigold nodded eagerly, but her expression changed after a moment.

"Say... Timothy? Are you feeling okay? You're acting a little... cold."

"Ah. It's because of the System." Timothy explained. "I accidentally toggled an option that changed me into a logical-thinking Psion. It'll wear off in half a day or so. Must have triggered it by accident when I was in the water and flailing around."

"Oh... when you were in the... water... so it's like that." Marigold said quietly. "Well, as long as it's temporary. I'm just glad you're okay! So yeah, I'll see you tomorrow then! Kyargh!"

Timothy walked over and kissed Marigold's snout. She giggled, then skipped away, leaving him to stare at her as she departed.

Timothy felt absolutely nothing for Marigold in that moment. He only kissed her because social dynamics said it was the right thing to do. But all his passion and lust had evaporated once he initialized the Mind of Logic.

He realized Ferral was right. This wasn't who he was. The Mind of Logic turned him into a cold-hearted robot. He didn't want to give up his humanity, even if it meant being a technically 'superior' life form.

As Timothy walked into his house, he stared into the ever-present darkness on Chrona. The pitch-black hallways yawned in front of him, feeling no more fearsome than the light.

"Flaws make us human. I should not cast them aside too quickly, lest I lose what makes me... *me*."

He looked to his right. Just inside the door, there was a plastic bag with two boxes of cold food. The nurse had bagged things up nicely for him.

Timothy snatched the food up and walked into the dining room. He still had two-thirds of his daily food requirements to eat, and he wasn't THAT hungry yet. It had only been four hours since he overstuffed himself.

Still, he wanted to complete the quest, no matter what. Pushing his pain down, Timothy shoveled large mouthfuls of the cold meat and veggies into his mouth. He chewed them with limited enjoyment, feeling his stomach scream and beg for mercy.

He was absolutely going to die on the toilet within an hour or two.

Eventually, Timothy finished his food. He might be in a logical state of mind, but that did not stop the emotional agony of shoveling a dump truck's worth of food into his gullet. He wanted to pass out in his room, but he was in too much pain to sleep.

"Fuck. Fuck. God, this hurts... so bad." Timothy cursed.

He clutched his stomach and massaged it, hoping to provoke a burp that wasn't followed by vomit. At the same time, he pulled up his Quest screen. He had completed the daily quest.

It was time for his well-earned rewards.

Without hesitation, Timothy accepted Ferral's quest rewards.

His EXP, which was at 53/114, instantly shot up 50 EXP to 103/118 after the first Ferral objective, then it gained another 38 EXP and blinked into Level 2, at 23/138 EXP.

He had leveled up again!

But Timothy didn't stop there. He accepted the next EXP reward from his pullups daily quest, which had been doubled to 76 EXP. He rose to 99/138 EXP for his final value of the day! He had nearly leveled twice!

Most importantly, his gut digestion rose by 5%. It felt like a tiny bit of the pressure in his stomach was alleviated, but he couldn't be certain. His END and CON both rose by 5%, his maximum movement speed rose by 10%, his swimming speed by 5%, and his eyesight even improved slightly.

He obtained two Lootboxes. One was a plain and basic Tier 1 Lootbox, but the other was a 'Mundane Skill Lootbox'. Timothy was very interested in seeing what that entailed. Mundane options didn't seem very good, but who could say for sure?

Timothy took a moment to think about what he wanted to do next. He decided to look at the Level Up options.

Level 2 Achieved.

First Reward: 1x Reroll Token. 1x Banish Token. 3x Lock Token.

Second Reward: Choose one of three new King Network Features to unlock. Can be saved for later.

Third Reward: Improve two of your skills by +1 levels. You cannot improve the same skill multiple times.

Fourth Reward: Get +1 to Party Slots OR get 1x Rare Ability Lootbox.

The first reward was a no-brainer. Timothy accepted it, bringing himself to x3 of all the token items. That would be useful for when he was manipulating Lootboxes and other similar options in the future.

The second reward made his heart jump. He tapped on it, and three new features appeared, prompting him to select one.

[Pawn Summoning]

The Player may summon a Pawn from across time and space to accompany them on their journey. The Pawn is random and cannot be chosen, but unwanted pawns can be discarded and re-summoned every set period of time. The period of time can be influenced by many factors. Pawns are NPCs that can either be mindless robotic companions or full-fledged characters with their own journeys and desires.

[Crafting System]

The Player will gain access to Crafting, allowing them to craft a huge variety of items, skills, talents, and weapons. However, this system does not fully unlock until later levels, and requires resources to make work properly. It is a cheaper alternative to the STORE, but the STORE is more convenient in what it offers.

[Create Dungeon]

The Player is often limited in ways they can gain EXP by the Quests available to them. Dungeons solve this issue. The Player can create an instanced Dungeon to venture inside and slay monsters, collect loot, and level up. Items obtained in the dungeon can be brought outside. Dungeons must be completed once opened, or else they may Dungeon Break, causing all the monsters inside to spill out into reality. This is very dangerous, and should be prevented if possible. Only Players may enter Dungeons, unless the Dungeon Break event has occurred, in which case non-Players can enter as well.

Timothy's heart became moved. He started to tremble as he looked at these three options available to him. Every single one offered a ton of utility and features. He desperately wanted to obtain all three, but he could only pick one.

"If I had to choose, I think Crafting will be fantastic later on, but it has little use for the me of now. Pawn Summoning sounds amazing! But it won't help me level up faster right now. Creating Dungeons is by far the option that best solves my dilemma. Ferral and I could go inside and fight monsters together!"

But Timothy did not select any of the options. He wisely chose to leave the choice to tomorrow, where he would discuss it with Ferral.

"Shit. Maybe Ferral already picked one of these options! He hit Level 2 before me, after all. I definitely need to check with him, first."

Timothy looked at the Third Reward next. He obviously picked Eye of Yredelemnul to evolve it to Level 3, then he chose Crocodile Form to evolve it to Level 2. This was mainly so he could see how it would change.

[Eye of Yredelemnul L3] [MP Cost 0] [AP Cost 0] [Cooldown 0]

The stolen power of a dark god courses through the Player. The Player can examine objects and entities with the Eye of Yredelemnul to learn more information about them. As the Player strengthens, the information available to them will improve drastically.

Improved: The Eye can now see the stats of other entities.

Improved: The Eye can sense the auras of powerful life forms.

[Crocodile Form L2] [Active Skill] [Rare] [Transformation] [Holistic] [90 Mana (Sustained) OR 9 AP (Activated)] [No Cooldown]

The Player gains the ability to transform into a half-crocodile, gaining all the upsides and downsides that come along with such a transformation. Their skin will become hardened and scaled, granting bolstered defense. Their muscles will increase in density. They become incredibly adept in water. However, their mind will slow down somewhat. The player can revert back to their original form for free at any time.

Grants +60% STR, DEX, CON, and HP, with doubled improvements when in water. Grants -45% INT and WIS.

Timothy's eyes widened. This was a shocking level of improvement! Yredelemnul's Eye went from only seeing basic stats to seeing all stats, and it even gave him the ability to see powerful life forms. He wasn't entirely sure what that meant, but it seemed extremely useful.

And Crocodile Form became even better! Not only did its upsides improve, and its downsides decrease, but its activation requirements dropped as well. He only needed 90 MP to activate it now instead of 100! And since the form's stats doubled when in water, the 10% increase to STR, DEX, CON, and HP were actually 20% when he was swimming!

If this kept up, would Crocodile Form become free to use at Level 10?

Timothy exhaled deeply. He groaned and rubbed his aching stomach.

"Shit. I should have asked Marigold to be my girlfriend officially. Then I could have gotten a permanent +10% to my EXP gains. Whatever, I'll just do it tomorrow."

He still had the final Reward to accept, on top of opening Lootboxes and other such things, but the young man simply wasn't in the mood. He was dog-tired from all his training.

He staggered out of the kitchen, flopped into bed, and cried as his stomach hit the mattress. He would have to worry about the new System feature tomorrow.

After a moment, he moaned painfully.

"...Oh god. *I need to take a shit*."

Part 688: A New Player?

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy woke up later than usual, around 10 AM. His body didn't ache, likely because of his Player abilities, but his mind did, even if only a little.

He opened up his repeatable quests. All of them were due to reset two hours later, at noon, so there wasn't any point in doing pushups or other exercises early. He was feeling a little bored, so he flipped through his video games and thought about playing one.

"Hmm. Fighting game? Nah, not interesting anymore. RPG? I already do that in real life. Racing?"

Timothy fell silent for a moment. He remembered when he was a kid and his mom sometimes played video games with him. The only games she liked playing were racing games. She really enjoyed jumping in a car and zipping around race-tracks at high speed. Apparently, before she had split from Phoebe, Fiona had loved to go racing on Tarus II.

But she never had time to do that anymore. Now that she ran Chrona all by herself, she was too busy to cruise around in a car... and Chrona didn't have any cars anyway, or any long roads she could use to race on. Thus, she sometimes played racing games with her son. But that was years and years ago. She hadn't played them since Timothy was maybe six or eight years old.

This made him feel... nothing. Timothy supposed he should feel glum, but the faint nostalgia just didn't do much for him.

In that moment, Timothy felt a different kind of pain. It was the pain of loss. He wanted to feel sad, but he couldn't. The System had dulled his emotions so much that he felt completely hollow. He leaned back in his beanbag chair, opened up his abilities page, and looked at his States of Mind. The 24 hour cooldown had finally ended.

Mind of Simplicity: Activate.

Timothy send out a mental command. Immediately his mental state altered. The world became a little more colorful. His interest in playing games returned, at least somewhat. But he wasn't really in the mood to do that anymore.

"I should go talk to mom before I hang out with Ferral and Marigold." Timothy said to himself quietly.

And so he did. Timothy got up, showered, cleaned himself up, then headed out. As he walked the short distance, he reviewed his tasks for the day.

I need to choose a new System feature. The choices are between Pawn Summoning, Crafting, and Create Dungeon. I also need to determine if I would rather have +1 party member slots, or get a rare ability from the Lootbox. On top of that, I have a Tier 1 Lootbox to open, and a Mundane Skill Lootbox!

Timothy's thoughts shifted.

I should make things official with Marigold today. Or... should I? It's not right to want to use her to obtain better benefits from my System while she gets nothing in return. Ferral's right. I should consider inviting her into the King Network.

Timothy arrived at the Spynet Sphere. He knocked a few times on the door, and his mom opened it.

"Oh, Timothy." She said softly. "I wasn't expecting you."

Timothy smiled sheepishly. "I, uh, I thought a lot about what you said yesterday, mom."

Fiona eyed her son for a few seconds, then she waved her hand backward. "That's good. Come on in, then."

When Timothy entered, he found Blinker and Kar were still there. Or they had visited a second time? He wasn't sure. It didn't seem likely they had spent an entire day in the Spynet, but they *were* immortals with little need for sleep.

"Aunt Blinker, Uncle Kar." Timothy said, smiling weakly. He felt exposed without the Mind of Logic. He lacked confidence, and it showed.

"You look tired." Blinker observed. "Are you doing alright?"

"Yeah. I've been doing a lot of physical training with Ferral. Intense, but safe. Mainly pushups, pullups, situps, that sort of thing. I even went for a really long run with him yesterday."

Fiona crossed her arms and nodded. She sat in a chair at the same round table as Kar and Blinker. Timothy sat in the final chair, closest to the entry doors.

"So." Fiona said, her tone oddly calm. "Have you thought about what sort of man you want to be?"

"I've been reckless. I'm sorry." Timothy said, lowering his eyes. "But... after thinking about it, I realized this really is who I am. I don't want to sit around in comfort inside Chrona. I want to become someone amazing. Now that I have my Heroic abilities, I can't shake this feeling. It's as if I've heard a calling from a greater power."

Kar chuffed. "Hurgh. Perfectly sensible words! A boy wants to become a man. I see no problem with this."

"The problem isn't your aspirations." Blinker gently said, reaching over to touch Timothy's hand that was resting on the table. "It's the reckless, thoughtless way you've been using your powers. You keep throwing yourself into danger without thinking of the consequences."

Timothy nodded. "I know. I won't be doing that anymore."

He turned and smiled at Fiona. "I'm sorry I worried you, mom. From now on, I'm going to assess my risks much more carefully. Just because I'm offered a Quest doesn't mean I'll take it. I can ignore dangerous ones and focus on slow, incremental gains. I have plenty of time to take my growth slow inside Chrona, anyway."

Fiona seemed to release a breath she had been holding. It appeared she was somewhat relieved..

"That's... that's good, Timothy. I hope you understand that with all the lying you've done recently, I can't fully trust you. But... hopefully you'll start walking a better path now. Don't follow in your father's earliest footsteps. He made a lot of simple mistakes that caused him no end of grief."

Timothy nodded humbly. "Yes, mom."

A moment of levity followed. His apology was simple, but direct. He took full accountability for his failures, which made everyone feel relieved.

Timothy looked around the table.

"There's another reason I came here. Two, actually. I need to use the Spynet to look at as many different animals and sentients of as diverse an array of power as possible. I also wanted to offer you and Uncle Kar a chance to become... Players."

Fiona blinked. "Young man, you are not touching the Spynet for the foreseeable future."

"No, no, mom, it's not like that." Timothy explained. "I have this skill, it's called 'Eye of Yredelemnul', and it allows me to see the stats of other lifeform-"

"It's called WHAT?!" Fiona shrieked, jumping up and looking at Timothy in horror. "What did you just say? Yredelemnul?! Like that horrible, horrible thing Jason mentioned? The monstrosity on Pixiv?!"

Blinker's eyebrows jumped. "My home world? What are you talking about?"

Blinker might be a Fairy Queen, but that was only in terms of her power. She had never returned to Pixiv to learn the ancient secrets, nor had she been formally inducted. She only cared about living with Kar, so she only thought she might go there in the future if the option casually arose. She had no interest in returning for any special reason.

"The Eye of Yredelemnul..." Fiona said, looking at Timothy with deeply frightened eyes. "Jason... Jason saw it! It's a horrible, horrible thing that Queen Calanthra keeps locked away inside her palace on Pixiv. It used to belong to a dark god, and still contains the power of a Ruler! She used it to pierce through dimensions into a place called 'Ripspace.' That's how the fairies traveled from Andromeda to the Milky Way..."

It was fortunate that Jason always kept his spiritual wife in the know with regards to matters like this. She might never have realized Timothy was harboring some horrible fragment of evil inside himself. No wonder he had been acting so strangely. This might even be the reason why he had done something as shameful as peeping on girls like a weird, creepy voyeur!

At least, those were Fiona's initial thoughts. Timothy slowly stood up and raised his hands.

"Mom, it's not like that. It's just the name of the ability. Look, let me list out my abilities and what they do. You'll understand then."

And so he did. Despite having only an hour before he needed to meet with Ferral and Marigold, Timothy took the time to explain his abilities to the others. He wrote down their descriptions and effects, but that didn't stop his mother from continuing to remain spooked.

"Timothy, this power can act as benign as it wants. Even the description says 'The stolen power of a dark god courses through the Player'. If that isn't evil, then what is it?"

Kar lifted his snout. "It says 'stolen'. That means it was not given freely. The weapon of an enemy can still be useful, White Ghost."

"I'd feel better if I could talk to Calanthra." Blinker said while chewing a fingernail. "I agree with Fiona. This power sounds dangerous. But if it hasn't manifested any obviously evil effects, then..."

Timothy threw his hands up. "Look, I just need to examine lots of entities with the Spynet, okay? It allow me to alter my baseline understanding of other creatures so my stat system can become more accurate. Mom, will you help me?"

Fiona struggled with whether she should allow Timothy's request or not. Ultimately, her motherly love won out. She wrung her hands together in consternation, then sighed. "Alright. Alright! I'll show you some people and animals. But I'm in full control, got it?"

It was obvious she didn't trust him not to go peeping on girls again. Though, now that Timothy had experienced the real thing, he had also lost a lot of interest in voyeurism.

"That's fine, mom. Thank you."

Fiona walked over to the computer. She gestured toward the Spynet, where dozens of screens showed various people and places that were being observed at all times.

"Well?" She asked.

Timothy paused. He started rapidly activating the Eye of Yredelemnul to load the stats of one human, demon, and Volgrim after another. Each time he did, Timothy's own stats started to change. When Fiona showed him images of the Volgrim leaders, his stats went down. All of them were extremely powerful in a variety of ways. When she showed him random animals on random planets, his stats went up. Those animals represented the baseline for weakness.

Timothy had his mom cycle through dozens of different Sentients. Before long, his stats had reached a point where they weren't changing anymore. They had normalized, along with the stats of all the other sentients.

A pop-up appeared in front of Timothy.

Congratulations, Administrator. You have scanned 117/100 required unique living entities. You have unlocked the Bestiary.

Timothy blinked. This was a completely unexpected acquirement. He looked at his tabs, and there was a new tab available that said BESTIARY. He opened it up.

A large interface opened in front of him, complete with pictures, video, stats, and other information about all the creatures and sentients he had scanned. He could look at any of them to learn more information.

Another pop-up appeared.

The Bestiary collects all known and pertinent knowledge regarding scanned creatures. The more you know about a creature, the more information that will appear. The player can acquire combat bonuses against certain creatures by learning more about them. Upgrading the Eye of Yredelemnul will also grant the Bestiary additional info on newly scanned creatures.

That certainly sounded useful. Timothy opened his Character page to check his stats.

Timothy Hiro - Human/Chrona

Level 2 | Newbie | Bottom Mortal

Exp: 99/138

AP: 0/0 | MP: 0/0

STR 10 | DEX 10

INT 9 | WIS 8

DEF 9 | RES 9

CHA 8 | LUK 10

CON 10 | END 11

Timothy opened up Ferral's stats as well, now that those had been properly normalized.

Learner Ferral - Psion/Chrona/Volgrim

Level 2 | Newbie | Low Mortal

HP 514/514

AP 14/14 | PP 78/78

STR 11 | DEX 11

INT 10 | WIS 9

DEF 11 | RES 10

CHA 7 | LUK 9

CON 11 | END 13

It turned out the massive rift from before where Ferral seemed vastly further ahead of Timothy was actually a relatively small gap. Timothy was weaker than the baseline Sentient. Ferral was a little stronger. But the gap was definitely possible to close, if Timothy worked hard.

With a thought, Timothy pulled up another Sentient he had scanned with his mother's permission.

Emperor Belial AKA "Samantha" - Demon/Sharmur

Non-Player | High Mortal

HP 737/737

AP 52/52 | MP 810/810

STR 18 | DEX 18

INT 13 | WIS 14

DEF 12 | RES 11

CHA 17 | LUK 13

CON 12 | END 16

Her stats were absolutely insane. Timothy stared with wide-eyed shock at her page. He couldn't believe what he was seeing. 20 was the theoretical limit, with each point upward being vastly harder and harder to attain. If he went against Belial, he would lose. End of story.

His aunt sure was amazing!

"Thanks, mom." Timothy said. "I just unlocked a new feature called the Bestiary."

He quickly explained to her how it worked, and she raised an eyebrow.

"Really? And what are my 'stats' then?"

Timothy checked.

Fiona Hiro - Phantasmal Human/Chrona

Non-Player | Bottom Mortal

HP 45/45

AP 2/2 | MP 71/71

STR 8 | DEX 13

INT 17 | WIS 18

DEF 8 | RES 9

CHA 13 | LUK 13

CON 7 | END 19

Timothy looked at his mother's stats with even greater surprise! He wrote them down for her, and she appeared equally surprised.

"My endurance is extremely high. That is likely because I'm a phantom that doesn't ever get physically tired. I'm surprised your 'System' rates my intelligence and wisdom so highly."

"I'm not." Timothy said, smiling at his mom. He looked away, slightly embarrassed, then lowered his voice. "...I've always thought you were the smartest person in the universe."

"Oh, honey..." Fiona said, revealing a warm smile. "That's so sweet of you to say."

Timothy grinned sheepishly, then turned and looked back at Blinker and Kar, who had remained seated.

He checked both their stats with a glance.

Monster Queen Blinker - Fairy/Chrona/Pixiv

Non-Player | High Mortal

HP 514/514

AP 11/11 | MP 1204/1816

STR 14 | DEX 16

INT 18 | WIS 15

DEF 14 | RES 14

CHA 16 | LUK 14

CON 11 | END 13

Monster King Kar - Crocodile/Chrona

Non-Player | Bottom Mortal

HP 75/75 (-1206)

AP 3/3(-75) | MP 14/14(-503)

STR 9(-8) | DEX 10(-5)

INT 14 | WIS 14

DEF 10(-8) | RES 10(-7)

CHA 9 | LUK 9

CON 9(-9) | END 8(-9)

Blinker and Kar's stats were even crazier! Timothy could tell Belial and Blinker were roughly equal, each with their own strengths, but he couldn't see any information beyond their stats. Whatever unique skills they had would likely decide the victor if they came to blows.

But it was Kar's stats that broke Timothy's heart.

"Hey, Umi." Timothy whispered. "Why are there minus-numbers next to my uncle Kar's stats?"

Umi blinked to life. "**The Sentient 'Kar' is not a Player character. I am unable to provide detailed information on him.**"

"Well okay, but what do negative numbers *usually* mean?" Timothy asked.

"**They would often indicate a debuff or affliction reducing a character's stats.**" Umi replied emotionlessly. "**Unless the entity known as 'Kar' joins the King Network, more detailed information cannot be obtained.**"

Timothy hesitated. He had his own theory. Kar had been killed and revived, but had lost all of his former power. What if that power was still inside of him, and thus his stats were majorly debuffed, but they could be recovered? What if making him a Player could restore him to the way he once was?

Timothy chewed his lip. He looked at his mom, who glanced back.

"What?" Fiona asked. "Are you going to share with the class?"

Timothy slowly nodded. He grabbed a notebook, then scribbled down his stats, his mom's stats, then Blinker and Kar's stats. He walked over to the table and placed the notepad down.

"Like I said earlier," Timothy explained. "I was thinking of turning you and Kar into Players. Then you could level up and get stronger like me. And Uncle Kar... I think it would benefit you the most. You um... you used to be really strong, right? You could become strong again. Maybe even more powerful than before!"

Blinker and Kar looked at the notepad, comparing themselves to Timothy and Fiona.

"...What do these negative numbers mean?" Kar asked. "Hurgh. They do not look good."

"I'm not entirely sure." Timothy admitted. "But I think they're what your stats would be if you weren't... uh..."

"Crippled?" Kar asked, looking up at Timothy.

"I- I wouldn't use that word specifically..." Timothy said, trailing off.

Kar chuffed. He tapped the notepad, then looked at his wife. After staring into her beautiful eyes for a moment, he looked back at Timothy.

"It is tempting to accept the offer. But didn't you say before that you have limited slots available?"

"Yeah..." Timothy muttered. "I only have two. I was actually thinking of inviting Marigold to be a Player too, and I currently have the choice of adding one Player slot or obtaining a rare and powerful Skill. I'm just... not sure what to do."

Kar leaned back in his chair.

"Game Boy. I am content with my life. Butterfly and I are bringing back the crocodiles. The Battle Bastards who killed my people are both dead. I no longer have any need to attain power. I may be weak, but I am surrounded by family members who love me. Yes, as a man it is tempting to desire power simply to act big and tough. But I have never sought power for power's sake. It is of no consequence to me."

He waved his hand toward Fiona. "White Ghost. You should become a Player, like your son. You are the core of Chrona. If you can gain powerful new abilities, you may be able to save our decaying dimension. As for me, I will pass on this opportunity. I thank my wonderful nephew for offering, but you should give this opportunity to the younger generation. Little Marigold seems a fine mate for you."

Fiona looked at Kar, then she looked at Timothy and frowned. "Are you sure you want to give your girlfriend this power? You barely know her, right? Don't you think you should be in a more committed relationship first?"

Timothy shrugged. "The sooner she becomes a Player, and you as well mom, the sooner you guys can start leveling up and becoming stronger. Don't you think that's for the best?"

Fiona shrugged her shoulder helplessly, than shook her head. "You can do as you please, Timothy. I do admit... this power of yours could fulfill a lot of my strategic objectives. With Jason gone, I've been heaping all the magical work onto Blinker's shoulders. Do you think your game power could give me magical abilities?"

Timothy immediately nodded. "A hundred percent it will, mom. You will get to complete quests, and those quests give rewards you can use to pursue the type of power system you want to develop. I think it'll be a big upgrade for you."

Fiona didn't seem especially excited, but she did privately think that using the power would help her better understand it. In secret, she was terrified her son had bitten off more than he could chew. The more she knew, the better she could foresee future problems and protect him. She was especially horrified by the revelations of Yredelemnul being somehow involved in Timothy's power. She could never forgive herself if her son

turned into some dark god's slave by using a power that wasn't really his. What if Timothy wasn't a Trueborn Hero at all, but an unwitting pawn of something or someone evil?

She would die before she let that happen.

"...Alright. Turn me into a Player, then." Fiona finally said.

Timothy nodded. He activated the System's invite function, and his mother flinched. A giant screen had appeared right in front of her face.

[AN ADMINISTRATOR IS INVITING YOU TO THE KING NETWORK.]

[IF YOU ACCEPT THIS REQUEST, YOU WILL BECOME A PLAYER.]

[WILL YOU ACCEPT THE FRIEND REQUEST AND JOIN TIMOTHY HIRO'S PARTY?]

[YES | NO]

Fiona stared blankly.

"What do I do?" She asked.

"Just press 'Yes', mom." Timothy said.

And so she did. Fiona Hiro activated the King Network and became the third Player to join its ranks.

None present could have foreseen how her ascension would someday drastically change the galaxy's balance of power...

Part 689: Fiona's Ascension

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Fiona accepted the Player invitation request. After a moment, she looked around and blinked.

"Okay? Now what?"

Timothy pointed to her right. "Look at the edge of your vision. Do you see those tabs that say Character, Inventory, and so on? You can either tap them with your finger, or think of opening them with your mind."

"Oh! I see!" Fiona said. "So I just think the word, and it- OHH! That scared me!"

Fiona recoiled slightly, visibly flinching when she opened her Character Sheet. Now that she was in Timothy's Party, he could see more detailed information about her.

Fiona Hiro - Phantasmal Human/Chrona

Level 0 | Newbie | Bottom Mortal

HP 45/45

AP 2/2 | MP 71/71

STR 8 | DEX 13

INT 17 | WIS 18

DEF 8 | RES 9

CHA 13 | LUK 13

CON 7 | END 19

Resistances: Physical 95%. Telepathy 100%.

Weaknesses: Magic 95%.

Active Skills: Mother's Intuition, Construct Item, Deconstruct Item

Passive Skills: Player's Body, Player's Mind (Toggle), Phantasmal Entity

Talent Slots: 0/1

Prestige: N/A

Timothy's eyes widened. "Ooh, mom! You have some skills already! You should look at them. Write them down so we can see what they do!"

Fiona blinked. "Skills? I do? Oh, I see them. Sure, give me a moment."

She grabbed the notepad Timothy had been using, then started to write down every skill's description, word for word. This was helpful, because other Players could not see what exactly her skills were, even if they were in the same Party. Party members could see skill names, but not descriptions. Non-party members couldn't even see that much.

Mother's Intuition: [Unique] [MP Cost 5]

You are always worrying about the status of your adopted child. When this skill is activated, you will be able to sense Player Timothy's exact location and the area around him, no matter the distance. This effect cannot be blocked by any means. You may also heal your child's wounds by placing your palm on the injured area and meditating. Your child will recover 5% of his maximum HP every hour, and will heal through extreme damage states, such as [Lightly Wounded], [Injured], [Maimed], and [Broken].

Construct Item: [Ordinary] [MP Cost 50]

You are able to construct any item you wish, provided you have adequate raw materials immediately at hand and you possess a detailed mental blueprint of how the item should be constructed. The item will be constructed within 30 seconds and will be fully charged and ready to use, if applicable. The items you can construct are limited by your level and knowledge.

Deconstruct Item: [Ordinary] [MP Cost 50]

You are able to disassemble any item and copy its blueprints into your Mind Realm. The item will be deconstructed within 30 seconds. By doing this, you can perfectly recreate the item with the Construct Item skill. Note that some items may need to be deconstructed multiple times to acquire their full blueprints.

Phantasmal Entity: [Passive] [Racial]

You are a phantasmal entity made corporeal by the energy contained within Chrona. You are extremely resistant to physical damage and your body cannot be harmed by mundane means. However, you are exceptionally weak to magical damage and must take care when battling spellcasters. Due to your special existence, when obtaining Lootboxes, you have one additional option to choose from, and you also gain an additional bonus when leveling up. Lastly, you are capable of multiclassing and switching between your available classes with no cooldown time.

Timothy's jaw dropped when he saw these four outrageous skills. He thought his abilities were good when he first became a player, but they were nothing compared to Ferral and Fiona's basekits.

"Oh my gosh, that first skill is so embarrassing." Fiona said, blushing. "The System makes it seem like I'm some overly worried *priss* or something."

"Mom, the skill says you'll see everything around me when you use it." Timothy said, feeling somewhat violated. "So... you'd better take care. You never know what, um, weird things you might see. Like, uh, me and my girlfriend, for instance."

"Oh, please! I cleaned your butt when you were a baby!" Fiona exclaimed. "There's nothing down there I haven't already been grossed out by!"

"Mom!! Eww! Not in front of Aunt Blinker and Uncle Kar!" Timothy protested.

Blinker snorted. "Kid, I changed your diapers too. Had to give Fiona a few days off once in a while."

"Hurgh. Your Little Timmy was always a strange sight." Kar chimed in, grinning evilly at the brutal blow he dealt to his nephew's heart.

Timothy staggered. The consecutive strikes against his manhood dimmed his resolve. He knew he'd lost this argument.

"R-right. Well, you have two other active skills as well. It seems you can use them now! You can construct and deconstruct items. Mom, why don't you grab something you don't know much about, that isn't too valuable, and deconstruct it right here?"

Fiona blinked. She thought about it for a moment, then nodded.

"Well, I've maintained them, but it was actually Jason who built all the monitors in the Spynet. Blinker, can you grab that dead monitor up there and decouple it for me?"

She pointed to the ceiling, where several monitors had gone dark due to losing connection with their spy-points. Unfortunately, the Spynet was losing a monitor every month or so, and in just a few year's time most of them likely wouldn't work anymore.

Blinker nodded. She flew up, used her telekinetic powers to carefully wiggled a monitor out of place, then she unplugged it and brought it down to Fiona.

Fiona frowned as Blinker placed the giant monitor on a table. "So... how does this work?"

"I don't know." Timothy admitted. "I imagine you just... touch the monitor, then think of activating the skill?"

A few seconds passed. Fiona traced her hands along the monitor's edge. All of a sudden, a blue light erupted from her mind and wrapped around the monitor. It levitated a few inches off the table, then began rapidly disassembling itself. Fiona's eyes widened with fascination as thousands of internal circuit designs flowed into her mind, each one detailing how the others should all connect. The monitor flew apart into individual pieces faster and faster, ultimately crumbling into a pile of plastic shell components, metal bits and screws, copper wiring, and other such things.

In less than ten seconds, she had completely taken the monitor apart.

"I... I see it!" Fiona exclaimed. "There's a blueprint in my mind. It's a perfect diagram of every inch of the monitor! I can even use my existing knowledge base to rework its functions and improve it!"

Fiona was extremely talented when it came to learning how to make and manufacture technology, but she wasn't omniscient. She had countless holes in her knowledge base. She had been enhanced by Solomon's Crown when she was still Phoebe, and those gains remained after their split, but she was no bio-computer, like Rebecca.

Even so, she realized immediately that if she only had these two skills, the ability to rip apart and rebuild objects, she would progress tens of times faster than she did as a mere ghost-turned-physical.

"That was incredible!" Blinker exclaimed. "If this is the level you're already at, what will you become if you grow over the comings weeks, months, and years?"

She glanced at Kar. There was a hint of yearning on her face.

Kar held up a palm. "Butterfly. Say no more. I have made my decision. My vengeance is complete. I do not wish to seek the path of blood any longer. I am pleased White Ghost has become stronger, but that is all. Returning to the field of battle is not my desire."

Fiona continued to examine her new abilities. Unfortunately, it seemed her mana slowly regenerated at the rate of 1% every ten minutes. She would only recover 6% of her mana in an hour, and a maximum of 144% every 24 hours. Thus, she would not be able to use her Construct Item ability until she had risen above 50 Mana, which would take a while.

"Check your Quests, mom." Timothy said.

Fiona nodded. She opened them up, then listed them out on a piece of paper.

[Story Quest] [Continuous] Choose a Path.

You are a phantasmal life-form with unlimited potential. Your ability to adapt exceeds your expectation. At present, you have become a Technologist, and your current abilities reflect this, but you could become so much more. As you level up and obtain new abilities, those abilities will influence your future potential, allowing you to obtain unique and exotic professions.

Rewards: None.

[Story Quest] Master Your Abilities.

You have the ability to construct and deconstruct items. Use these abilities five times each. Complete the quest by constructing a unique item, device, weapon, or armor. If the item you construct passes a certain quality threshold, the rewards will be doubled or tripled respective to its quality.

[Construct Item: 0/5]

[Deconstruct Item: 1/5]

[Final Constructed Item Quality] [Mundane|Common|Uncommon|Rare+]

Rewards: 1x Technology Skill Lootbox. 1x Phantasmal Skill Lootbox. 1x Uncommon Item Lootbox. 1x Level Up. (Rewards can increase depending on final crafted item's quality.)

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Maintain Chrona.

Chrona's infrastructure is in decay. You must travel around Chrona and repair its core functionality each day, using your Map to uncover problem areas you may have previously overlooked. In order to obtain rewards, you must repair a quota of items every day. Repairing any multiple of that quota will increase the rewards, up to a maximum of x5 rewards.

[Repair Technological Devices: 0/5]

[Repair Magical Devices: 0/5]

Rewards: 3x Crafting Materials Lootbox, 1x Tier 2 Lootbox, 1x Temporary Phantasm

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Timothy did not envy his mother. Her quests gave insanely good rewards, but all of them required a lot of time and effort to achieve. Her story quest alone ensured multiple days of effort for a reward that might underwhelm if she couldn't craft a powerful enough final item.

One thing really caught Timothy's attention, though.

"Mom, your unique 'Racial Skill' gives you a huge bonus of +1 option when selecting Lootbox rewards... and almost all your rewards are Lootbox-related. This is a huge benefit. It means you get 33% more options compared to me. Make sure you consider every option carefully. Consult me, Blinker, Rebecca, and others to make sure you're considering all the possibilities."

His mom nodded. "I'm honestly a bit overwhelmed, Timothy. As soon as I saw the Quests, I felt this... this need... this desire to start immediately getting to work. Knowing that just standing here is 'wasting time' makes me itchy to get moving."

She frowned, then looked her son in the eye. "Timothy, is this how you've been feeling since you became a Player?"

He nodded. "Pretty much. Why?"

"Well. Maybe it's just my imagination. But... something about this feels predatory. Like it's tugging at my brain with incentives to get me doing what the System wants me to do."

"The System wants you to be stronger." Timothy pointed out. "What's the problem with that?"

Fiona looked uneasy. "It's probably nothing. Just my imagination. Well, I'd better get to work on these Quests. I'm eager to see what these Lootboxes really look like."

"And I need to head out." Timothy said. He walked over and gave him mom a long, tender hug. "I'll be hanging out with Ferral and Marigold. See you later, mom."

"Love you." She said.

"Love you too."

* * *

After grabbing a clipboard along with a pen and paper, then stuffing them in his inventory, Timothy headed out the door. He thought to himself as he walked away from the Spynet Sphere that his mother appeared to have already unlocked Crafting at level 0. That further added to the feeling he didn't need to pick it for now. She would definitely end up a much better craftsman than he ever would.

"Since Uncle Kar didn't want to become a Player, that means I probably don't need the +1 Party Member Slot reward. I can choose the Rare Lootbox option instead. That will give me a Mundane Lootbox, a Rare Lootbox, and a Tier 1 Lootbox. Umi, can I transfer lootboxes to someone else?"

Umi materialized. "**Negative. You cannot give Lootboxes to your mother to open so as to abuse her Racial skill.**"

"Dammit. Screw you, how did you know what I was thinking?"

"**Because you are an inferior biological with thoughts so primitive and transparent I would be a fool not to predict them.**" Umi blandly replied.

She vanished, and Timothy continued on his way to the swimming hole.

He arrived to find Ferral standing all by himself near the largest boulder placed beside the makeshift lake.

"Ferral! Where's Marigold?" Timothy asked.

[I sense her aura approaching. She is still a few minutes away.] Ferral replied. [Timothy, I saw that you invited your mother to become a Player. What of your plans to invite Monster King Kar?]

Timothy shook his head. "Uncle Kar turned me down. So... I think I'll be inviting Marigold to become a Player instead."

[You will? So you have made up your mind. Are you not worried that you are rushing into this situation a bit too quickly?]

Timothy frowned at Ferral. "Wasn't inviting her your idea? Now you're having second thoughts?"

[No. I am merely wondering how much thought you put into this invitation.] Ferral explained. [Neither you nor I have spoken to Marigold at length. You have only recently started getting to know her. Perhaps you would rather delay for a week or two?]

"Well, even if she doesn't take to the System well or she isn't great at leveling up, I think it's better to invite her sooner. That way she can get levels and rewards faster." Timothy explained. "Have you seen the situation in Realspace?"

[The Milky Way's prospects are far from optimistic.] Ferral observed. [Humanity is weak. The Dolgrimites have obtained a method to push back the Plague, but perhaps their way will only slow the bleeding. The demons are a looming threat. I am not certain how the future will play out.]

"Exactly. So the sooner we get people leveling up, the sooner we have future Heroes and powerhouses capable of fighting the Plague." Timothy explained. "Thus- oh! Marigold! You made it!"

Timothy's expression brightened. Marigold picked up the pace as she darted over to hug him.

"Kyargh! Timothy, it's good to see you again! Are you fully recovered from your hospital visit?"

Timothy kissed the side of her face. "I'm doing great. Actually, I wanted to invite you here to discuss something with Ferral and me..."

The young man took a few minutes to succinctly explain to Marigold his idea of making her a Player.

"You invited King Kar, but he didn't accept?" Marigold asked. "If he won't, then I definitely will! Leveling up with you seems like a dream come true!"

"I thought you might say that." Timothy said with a smile. "But I wanted to make sure. Here, just accept this invitation."

Marigold reacted with remarkable calm when the invitation window popped up in front of her.

[AN ADMINISTRATOR IS INVITING YOU TO THE KING NETWORK.]

[IF YOU ACCEPT THIS REQUEST, YOU WILL BECOME A PLAYER.]

[WILL YOU ACCEPT THE FRIEND REQUEST AND JOIN TIMOTHY HIRO'S PARTY?]

[YES | NO]

She rubbed her claws together. "Ooh, how fun! So what do I do?"

"Just hit the 'Yes' button with your hand, or think of the word 'Yes' in your head." Timothy explained. "Most System functions can be controlled with your hands or your thoughts interchangeably."

And so she did. Marigold was accepted into the King Network, and Timothy eagerly checked her page.

Marigold - Crocodile/Chrona

Level 0 | Newbie | Low Mortal

HP 214

AP 31/31 | MP 6/6

STR 13 | DEX 12

INT 11 | WIS 11

DEF 13 | RES 12

CHA 14 | LUK 15

CON 13 | END 12

Resistances: Blunt 45%. Sharp 33%.

Weaknesses: Magic 11%.

Active Skills: Charm, Lightning Dive, Death Roll, Wave Splash

Passive Skills: Player's Body, Player's Mind (Toggle), Crocodilian

Talent Slots: 0/1

Prestige: N/A

Timothy grinned. "Can you write down what your skills do?"

"My skills?" Marigold asked. "Timothy, don't you think it's a little personal, asking a girl about her skills?"

"Huh?" Timothy replied, momentarily giving her a dazed look. "Personal? I'll show you my skills first if you want."

Marigold's crocodilian tail flicked behind her. "If I tell you my skills, won't you know all my weaknesses? Then you'll be able to bully me..."

"Bully you?" Timothy snorted. "Look at your stats. You were holding out! You're way stronger than me. You'll be the one bullying me, for sure!"

She giggled. "I was just messing around. Do you have something I can write on?"

Timothy reached into his Inventory and pulled out the clipboard. It was a good thing he'd thought to snag one, considering how often he'd found himself needing to write things down regarding the System. He handed it to Marigold, and her clunky claws grabbed the pen and started writing.

Charm: [Active] [Hex] [5 AP]

You are an exceptionally beautiful crocodile, and possess the ability to charm other entities, influencing them to do your will. This ability is most effective on entities who are innately attracted to you, including members of the opposite gender and homosexual members of the same gender, among similar variants. The more times you use this ability on an entity, the stronger its effects.

Lightning Dive: [Active] [Movement] [3 AP]

A skill which allows you to instantly traverse 100 meters vertically underwater. You can dive downwards at speeds eclipsing other aquatic lifeforms; useful for allowing a sudden initial strike or for escaping pursuers. Entities you have grappled before using this skill have a chance to become [Stunned], making them paralyzed for several seconds. If they are vulnerable to asphyxiation, they may accidentally inhale water and begin to drown.

Death Roll: [Active] [Offense] [15 AP]

A brutal attack that can be used on land but is 100% more effective when underwater. Grab an opponent and violently spin them around, inflicting the status ailments [Stunned] and [Agony] while also creating multiple tearing wounds across their body. Can be used immediately after a [Lightning Dive] to great effect.

Wave Splash: [Active] [Offense] [Variable AP Cost]

A powerful water-manipulation attack, allowing you to blast a powerful wave of water outward. You must be in or near a large enough body of water to activate this skill. Concentrating to charge up the attack first will cost more AP, but will result in a much more forceful wave.

Crocodilian: [Passive] [Racial]

You are a Crocodilian, a powerful life-form with extreme advantages in aquatic and land environments, but limited adaptability in others. You cannot obtain the ability to fly. Your mental acuity will always suffer a 20% penalty compared to other species. In exchange, all quests and rewards related to aquatic biomes will grant 50% increased rewards.

Timothy digested these skills. The Charm skill, especially gave him pause.

So far, skills seemed to correlate to a person's innate abilities and identity. Was Marigold a temptress? Had he accidentally fallen for her wicked wiles?

"What's up with this skill?" Timothy asked, looking at her from the side. "Charm? Seems a little weird."

Marigold blushed. "You... don't think I'm charming? I'm not pretty?"

"Of course you are!" Timothy quickly corrected himself. "It's just, this is a little..."

"Daddy always said I was a charming girl!" Marigold explained. "This must be what he meant. And look at my other skills! Wow, I can summon a water wave? I wanna try that!"

Marigold quickly darted over to the swimming hole. There was a different crocodilian lifeguard up in the trees. He looked down on her and watched, leaning back casually in the branches while making sure nothing dangerous happened.

"Timothy! Timothy!" Marigold squealed. "How do I summon the big water wave? How? How??"

"Just think the skill's name in your mind, I guess." Timothy said.

Marigold furrowed her brow. She swept her palms behind herself, then thrust them forward while crying out in a weird way. "Hiyahh!"

...A lump of water rippled outward, then disappeared into the lake's waters a few feet away. It was utterly unimpressive.

Marigold stomped her foot. "What the heck was that! I wanted a wave, but it just made a little splash! How am I going to make the other girls jealous if this is all I can do?"

Timothy chuckled. "It seems to be a charge-up skill. Try maintaining your concentration for a bit before releasing the wave."

And so she did. Marigold held her palms behind her back before flinging them forward in a dramatic pose. "Hiyahhh!!"

This time, a visibly larger wave flew away from the shore and rushed out into the middle of the open water. It eventually fell back into the water and sent minor ripples throughout the lake, but Marigold was much more excited now that she had succeeded.

"Kyarrgh! This is great! Thank you, Timothy! I can't wait to start getting even stronger! This gift is going to make me the coolest crocodile in Chrona!"

Timothy smiled. "Well, becoming 'cool' isn't as important as becoming strong. Remember, you have a responsibility to grow yourself into a powerhouse that can support Chrona, and someday, humanity. A lot of people are going to be counting on you."

Marigold sobered her expression. "Right! Good point. Sorry, I got a little carried away. So, what next?"

"Well," Timothy said, "next we should probably start talking about quest-maxxing. I want to synchronize you and Ferral's daily quests so we can triple up and obtain massive gains quickly!"

He paused.

"Ah... and there's another thing we need to discuss. It's related to a really important major System feature I have a choice of unlocking. I still haven't entirely made up my mind."

Timothy looked at his level up option. The most important choice still remained.

Choose: Pawn Summoning / Dungeons / Crafting.

What option would he select?

Part 690: Journey's Beginning

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

"So. Ferral, since you know more about the System than Marigold, this is primarily directed at you, but Marigold, you can feel free to add your input." Timothy said. He paused before continuing. "I have a choice to make regarding a new System feature I can unlock. I can either unlock the Pawn Summoning system, the Dungeon system, or the Crafting system. I've already ruled out Crafting, at least for now, because my mom has Crafting. I'm torn between the other two."

Timothy explained what all three systems were in enough simplicity and detail that even Marigold could follow along. Ferral tapped his chin thoughtfully.

[Timothy, I was also given a choice of unlocking three game systems, though I have not yet decided which one I wished to unlock. Additionally, mine were a little different from yours. They were as follows...]

He proceeded to list them off.

[Devour Uniqueness]

You are what you eat. By consuming the dead or living bodies of sentient and non-sentient entities, you can absorb part or the entirety of what makes them Unique. This system does very little at first, but can rapidly empower the Player as they become able to consume more and more. However, due to Contamination, the Player must beware. Obtaining too many abilities can slowly alter the Player's biological makeup, including their mind. They may eventually transform into a dangerous monster with little to no self-awareness. Power comes at a price.

[Create Dungeon]

The Player is often limited in ways they can gain EXP by the Quests available to them. Dungeons solve this issue. The Player can create an instanced Dungeon to venture inside and slay monsters, collect loot, and level up. Items obtained in the dungeon can be brought outside. Dungeons must be completed once opened, or else they may Dungeon Break, causing all the monsters inside to spill out into reality. This is very dangerous,

and should be prevented if possible. Only Players may enter Dungeons, unless the Dungeon Break event has occurred, in which case non-Players can enter as well.

[Bestiary]

Learn about the creatures you encounter and log down their Unique features. Obtain powerful benefits by hunting mighty beasts. Learn the weaknesses of Sentients to use against them. Learn the specific loot drops of each creature and use that to target specific items and crafting materials. Splice the genetic material of researched creatures onto yourself and others; experiment to find powerful mutations. Eventually, grow your own mutated creatures to fight alongside you.

After Ferral explained his three options, he shook his head. [I was already thinking of choosing Create Dungeon. Devouring is not my style. I do not possess a mouth, and even if I can Devour by using a different method, this System does not suit me. The Bestiary seems useful, but I am too focused on advancing my Psionics to worry about collecting information on other sentient and non-sentient creatures. Thus, the Create Dungeon system is most useful to me.]

Timothy gaped at Ferral. "*Bestiary*? I have that unlocked right now! I scanned a bunch of people and creatures with my eye skill, and that unlocked the Bestiary. I didn't realize it was an entire major System on par with Create Dungeon! I think this seals the deal, then, doesn't it? Ferral, you should pick Create Dungeon, and I'll pick Pawn Summoning. If one of us can summon a Dungeon, then we all can benefit. Pawn Summoning sounds like it will be extremely useful, so I'd like to see what it can do. I'm also betting I'll be able to unlock Dungeons some levels in the future."

Timothy also thought about the fact that the Bestiary description for Ferral gave a lot more information on what it could do. It seemed it wasn't merely an information-collecting system, but one that provided real tangible benefits.

Marigold didn't have an opinion, since she had barely even started her Player journey. She just let the boys choose whatever they wanted. As such, Timothy selected Pawn Summoning, while Ferral selected Create Dungeon.

[Astounding.] Ferral said, a few minutes after he and Timothy had started scrutinizing their new systems. [I am currently able to summon one free dungeon every seven cycles.

The dungeon must be at my level, but there are other options for summoning more powerful dungeons. I must unlock them later, after fulfilling some unknown requirement. It also appears I will someday be able to select the type of dungeon I summon, as well as its level range and tier.]

"Pawn Summoning seems really cool too." Timothy said. "It's a bit weak right now, though."

Timothy looked at the menu carefully.

---PAWN SUMMONING---

The Player may only summon [ONE] Pawn at present. If the maximum number of Pawns are currently summoned, one Pawn must be killed or dispelled before another may be summoned.

[Summon Mundane Pawn] [Cost: None] [Cooldown: 24 Hours] [Duration: Unlimited]

Summon a pawn from across time and space that is equal to your strength or weaker. The Pawn will be mindless and lack intelligence. The Pawn has a small chance to contain intelligence, but this is unreliable. The Pawn will remain summoned until it dies, or the Player dispels it.

[Summon Simple Pawn] [Cost: Greater of 10% Player's Gold OR 100 Gold] [Cooldown: None] [Duration: Unlimited]

Summon a pawn from across time and space that is equal to your strength. The Pawn may be mindless, or it may possess intelligence. The Pawn can be a weaker version of a powerful entity. The Pawn will remain summoned until it dies, or the Player dispels it.

[Summon Intermediate Pawn] [Cost: Greater of 35% Player's Gold OR 10,000 Gold] [Cooldown: None] [Duration: Unlimited]

Summon a pawn from across time and space that is somewhat stronger than you. The Pawn will typically be intelligent, but has a chance to be mindless. The Pawn can be a weaker version of a powerful entity. The Pawn will remain summoned until it dies, or the Player dispels it.

[Summon Powerful Pawn] [Cost: Greater of 75% Player's Gold OR 1,000,000 Gold] [Cooldown: None] [Duration: Unlimited]

Summon a pawn from across time and space that is much stronger than you. The Pawn will always be intelligent. The Pawn may resist the Player's orders if the Player's strength is insufficient. The Pawn may rebel. The Pawn will remain summoned until it dies, or the Player dispels it, or the Pawn returns itself to the Void.

[Summon Legendary Pawn] [Cost: Greater of 100% Player's Gold OR 1,000,000,000 Gold] [Cooldown: None] [Duration: 1 Hour]

Summon an unfathomably powerful Pawn that will reach the absolute limits of the universe's power. The Pawn will be extremely intelligent and completely obedient to the Player, but can only exist for a short duration of time. The Pawn cannot be summoned if the Player does not possess the minimum quantity of gold pieces.

[Summon Chaotic Pawn] [Cost: None] [Cooldown: None] [Duration: Unlimited]

Summon an extremely powerful Pawn that is vastly stronger than the Player. The Pawn is uncontrollable, and will do as it pleases. The Player cannot command the pawn, but may attempt to negotiate with it. The Pawn is capable of killing the Player. If the Player has reached an extremely high level of personal power, they may be able to negate all previous downsides. If the Pawn is not killed, it will continue to exist at its own whims for the duration of its natural lifespan. Are you sure you want to do this?

Timothy stared hungrily at the options. They excited him and made him want to start playing around immediately, but he quickly sobered himself up and thought carefully about what he would do next.

Timothy had no gold. He had not acquired even one piece yet. He knew there was a Store function, but the System hadn't offered him a single coin as a reward for any of his Quests. That meant summoning anything other than a Mundane Pawn or a Chaotic Pawn was impossible, and for blatantly obvious reasons, Chaotic Pawns were a complete no-go. He would simply destroy Chrona, perhaps even the Milky Way, if he used an ability so idiotic.

But, it seemed that Mundane Pawns were completely harmless. He might as well give that a try, since there was an extremely long cooldown before he could summon another.

"Alright. I'm gonna summon my first pawn. Give me a moment."

He took a step back from the others, then stared at an open spot up ahead, near the giant boulder placed beside the swimming hole.

"Mundane Pawn... summon!"

Timothy didn't know what would happen. Without any fanfare, a figure simply... appeared. One second, he was not there. The next, he was.

Timothy summoned a male demon. He had two tiny horns on his head, and otherwise looked completely ordinary. He was quite burly, at six-feet tall, and had messy black hair. He wore a shabby-looking pinstripe suit, and Timothy noted that there was blood on it.

Timothy looked above the demon's head. There were bright green words suspended in midair.

[Demon Grunt - Paimon] [Class: Burrower]

Timothy looked up at those words, then he examined the demon before him.

"Uh... Paimon? Is that your name?"

The demon blinked his eyes. He looked to his left. Then he looked to his right.

"Yes, master. That is my name." Paimon said after a few moments. He gazed at Timothy. "Where am I?"

"You don't know?" Timothy asked. "You're inside a special dimension. I summoned you to be my pawn."

Paimon slowly blinked. "Oh. That explains a lot."

Timothy was surprised. It was clearly obvious this 'Paimon' wasn't some mindless drone. He possessed intelligence, which was supposed to be nearly impossible for a Mundane Summon. What luck!

"Can you tell me about yourself?" Timothy asked.

Paimon slowly blinked again. "I am Paimon. I aspire to become a Demon Emperor. Currently, I am nobody of note. What is your name, master?"

"I'm Timothy." Timothy replied. "This is Ferral. He's a Psion. And this is Marigold, my girl- uh... well, she's..."

Timothy glanced at Marigold. She looked back and met his eyes.

"Were you going to say girlfriend?" Marigold asked, batting her eyes.

Timothy smiled goofily. "Uh, yeah! I guess I'm kinda jumping the gun here, but... wanna make it official?"

"That wasn't a very romantic way to phrase it. But yes! I'd love to!" Marigold said cheerfully. She walked over and kissed Timothy's cheek, which made both of them blush.

Paimon simply stared.

"A human. A Psion. A Crocodile. What a strange group of people. I was under the impression all the crocodiles had gone extinct."

"Well, they nearly did." Timothy said, wincing slightly. "This realm has lots of them. Best you don't talk about that around them. They might bite your head off."

"Oh." Paimon said. "I would prefer to keep my head attached."

He rubbed his palms together.

"Master. I am... feeling uncertain regarding how I arrived here. I know that you command me, and that I must obey, but otherwise I have no recollection of how I arrived. Could you inform me of recent matters? Where is this place, and what is my purpose? For what reason have you summoned me?"

Timothy frowned. It seemed the System forced a small amount of information into Paimon's mind, but otherwise he had been brought here against his will and with no recollection of how. Was he a real entity that had existed in the past or future? Was he a copy of a living entity? Could he be considered a 'real person'? Timothy wasn't certain.

"Sure. I'll fill you in." Timothy said. "First, this place is called Chrona, and around here there are mainly crocodiles, with a few Psions like Ferral, and humans like myself..."

He spent the next ten minutes explaining the current circumstances to Paimon, who merely folded his hands behind his back and listened attentively. Despite his massive and bulky size, he had a refined aura to him, and seemed like a rather intelligent guy.

"I roughly understand the current situation." Paimon said. "Pardon my impudence, master, but what year is it?"

Timothy blanked out. "Uhh... I don't... I don't know how to answer that."

Paimon rubbed his chin. "I am a member of the First Hell. How fares the First Hell these days? You are a human, yet you do not appear to be afraid of me. This suggests a major societal upheaval has occurred. Either that, or you are absolutely certain of my loyalty and do not fear my attacking you. Both possibilities seem plausible."

Timothy shrugged. "Well, ever since the Plague started ravaging the galaxy, the Seven Hells have been in disarray. The Demon Deities are doing what they can to fight back, but it's mainly the Volgrim who are pressing back against the Swarm. Humanity has gained a major foothold, but my people are still recovering from two of our worlds being obliterated."

Paimon slowly blinked his eyes three times. It was clear that most of what Timothy just said had gone over his head.

"It... seems... a lot has changed. I have little understanding of the words you just spoke. I appear to have been transported to the future. Forgive me, master. I am behind the times and unaware of the current galactic situation. I would politely ask that you fill me in on the greater details at your convenience. It does not have to be right now."

Timothy nodded. "Sure thing. You're the first Pawn I've summoned, but I already like you."

"I like you as well. Which is strange." Paimon said, eyeing Timothy up and down. "I've always hated humans. But somehow, you remind me of someone."

"Someone? Who?" Timothy asked.

Paimon lightly shrugged. "I do not recall. It is only a faint impression that rests within my mind. I feel as if at some point I lost my hatred for humans, but I do not recall when. Perhaps this is because of your 'System' which summoned me."

"You don't seem too broken up about... you know... becoming my *pawn*." Timothy pointed out.

"I was a servant of the Demon Emperors. Now I am yours." Paimon replied. "The master may have changed, but my situation has not."

Timothy suddenly felt terrible. He had effectively enslaved a sentient being, and the situation was so normal for his slave that he didn't even voice a word of resistance.

Was this because of the System? Had it forcibly made Paimon more docile? Or was he like this before the System took him? Timothy still had no idea if he was a copy of a living

being or a revived sentient brought under Timothy's control. He felt both options were quite awful.

After vigorously debating all the options in his head, Timothy opted to silence his internal voices. Paimon was his Pawn now. That was neither good nor bad. What mattered was that Timothy intended to treat him well.

"Well, Paimon. I look forward to getting to know you better in the coming days." Timothy said, patting Paimon's shoulder. "But for now, I need to focus on some other stuff. We'll talk later."

Paimon bowed his head. "As you command, master."

Satisfied, Timothy walked over to Marigold.

"Ahem. Well, that was an awfully awkward way to make our relationship official. I wanted to be more romantic, but I blundered again."

"That's okay, Timothy!" Marigold crowed. "It's the thought that counts. You're cute when you stumble over your words. It means you really like me!"

"Yeah, I sure do." Timothy grinned. "Hey, while I've got you here, I need you to make a few Quests with Ferral and I both. It'll be a daily training Quest where you have to complete certain objectives every 24 hours. If you complete them properly, you'll get lots of items and level up quickly!"

"That sounds exciting." Marigold said. "How do I do that?"

Timothy explained the process. He brought Ferral over and formally updated both of their daily quests to be on the same level. Now Timothy had his ordinary daily Quest, a Training with Ferral Quest that perfectly matched the Daily Quest, and one with Marigold as well. At the same time, the other two mimicked him. They all had three copies of the same Quest, copies which would triple the rewards for doing the same thing in three instances. When Timothy jogged for 10 kilometers, he received three rewards from each of the quests, and so did Marigold and Ferral.

It was a complete exploit of the System!

There was only one caveat.

"Ew! No WAY I'm eating vegetables!" Marigold complained. "I eat meat. That's it! Veggies are icky! They stick to my teeth and taste really gross!"

Ferral looked at Timothy. [Crocodiles *are* carnivores.]

"Alright, that's fair. Just change the vegetable requirement to meat." Timothy said. "Think about it really hard and the Quest will change accordingly."

Marigold chuffed. "Kyargh. Fine! That works for me. So what are we going to do now?"

"We're going to get to training. Time's a-wasting!" Timothy said with a grin.

And so they did. They started off with their daily jog, and Paimon ended up running alongside them, with Ferral on the right, Timothy on his left, Marigold on Timothy's left, and Paimon on Marigold's left.

The group of four decided to run three circuits around the outside of Chrona's main city. As they did, Timothy pulled up the final rewards he hadn't chosen yet. These consisted of a Tier 1 Lootbox, a Mundane Skill Lootbox, and finally, a Rare Lootbox, since he had decided to skip on the extra Party slot.

"Mundane Skillbox." He said while jogging.

Efficient Eating: [Active Skill] [Mundane] [Utility] [8 Hour Cooldown]

The Player gains the ability to digest and absorb the nutrients of any food consumed in the next 15 minutes by an additional 20%. The Player will more efficiently convert their calories and protein into muscle, but can also gain weight much more quickly.

Polearm Knowledge: [Passive Skill] [Mundane] [Offense/Defense]

The Player gains basic to intermediate knowledge of how Polearms work. The player becomes relatively effective in combat when wielding Polearms, but still requires years of practice to become a true master. The Player can repair moderate damage to most Polearms due to knowledge of how they function.

Wilderness Junkie: [Passive Skill] [Mundane] [Survival]

The Player will gain the effective knowledge of a five-year human veteran in guerilla warfare. The Player gains the innate ability to survive effectively even on hostile worlds with dense jungles. The Player can naturally intuit most of which plants and animals are dangerous to consume, can craft various items to assist long-term survival in the event of a crash-landing or becoming stranded, and so on.

Timothy was surprised. All of these were extremely useful skills. Though basic, being able to immediately acquire knowledge on a topic was something he didn't know the System could do.

One of those skills was immediately useful for him, but the other two were only useful in the future. If he was going to go dungeon diving with Ferral and the others, then knowing how to use Polearms would be a great boon, but he immediately decided to pick Efficient Eating. Right now, having to stuff his face with food each day was going to make him sick, so being able to digest it much faster would be a huge help.

Then, he opened the Tier 1 Lootbox. There ended up only being three crafting items, but one of them stood out to Timothy. He decided to grab it for his mom.

Trifrancium (0.15 kgs): [Item] [Uncommon] [Crafting Material] [Exotic Energy]

An extremely rare fragment of Trifrancium. This exotic material can be used to power starship engines, and even a minuscule amount can possess enough energy to power a fusion reactor for centuries. Very dangerous. Highly unstable.

Finally, Timothy opened the Rare Lootbox. This time, he was truly stunned by what he saw.

Nekomimi Mask: [Item] [Rare] [Face Slot] [Stealth]

A lost fragment of an ancient item. Shaped like a Japanese Cat God, this mask looks rather silly but is effective at what it does. Hideki's mask grants the Player the ability to become unrecognizable when worn. Their aura will change, their voice will change, and their body will appear faintly illusory. Obviously, the mask itself will be quite distinct, but nobody will know who is under the Mask if the Player is cautious. Forged by a grandfather with love.

Neutralizer Bracelet: [Item] [Rare] [Wrist] [Utility/Survival]

A Volgrim-created item that allows the Player to resist the negative effects of time dilation by up to 90% while worn. Time Dilation can no longer kill the Player as long as they wear the bracelet. The Player may suffer extreme pain from time dilation at first,

but over time, that pain will wear off. If the Player takes off the bracelet, their body will immediately explode, and they will die. Only by returning to a stabilized dilation speed they were previously used to will they be able to safely remove the bracelet.

Lightning Dash: [Active Skill] [Rare] [Movement/Offense] [Cost: 1 Mana] [Cooldown: 5 Seconds]

The Player gains the ability to dash forward at the speed of light, traveling any distance in a straight line. If the Player's dash would result in colliding with an object, they will either stop right in front of the object, or smash into it. If their body is capable of withstanding the impact, they will release an extremely powerful shockwave that will deal immense damage to the point of collision. If they cannot resist the impact, the Player will instantly die. Best used as a method of rapid transit across vast distances.

All three results were amazing. Timothy didn't see much use in disguising himself, so the strange first object didn't have much value to him, but the second and the third were insanely useful!

"I just got the option to pick up a time dilation resistance bracelet!!" Timothy screeched. "This is amazing! If I take it, I'll be able to leave Chrona!"

Marigold gave him a weird look. "You *want* to leave? Why? Isn't Realspace super scary? It's way safer to live here."

"Oh, sure, sure." Timothy acknowledged. "I can become stronger here for a few years, but ultimately I wish to return to Realspace and help save the galaxy. I won't do it until I'm a lot more capable than I am now, though."

Ferral nodded as he jogged. [I believe this time dilation bracelet is a good item to acquire. At the very least, if something happens to Chrona, you will have a way to safeguard your life. Your mother would approve.]

Timothy glanced at the Lightspeed Dash ability. It was really *really* tempting to choose. Who wouldn't want the ability to move at the speed of light? The activation cost was practically nothing, and the cooldown was all but nonexistent. It was almost as good as teleportation!

But ultimately, he chose the thing that made his heart race the fastest. He picked the Neutralizer Bracelet and gleefully stuffed it inside his inventory. Someday, he'd definitely

find a good use for it. Maybe he'd even have his mom take it apart and learn how it worked. Then it would benefit everyone in Chrona!

But, for the foreseeable future, Timothy did not plan to leave.

His journey of self-improvement had only just begun.

Part 691: The Burning Deity

Far-Future Era. Noon, Day 20, AJR. Melodia.

The midday sunlight shone down on the planet of Sharmur. Humans, demons, and monsters alike were working hard to continue building up humanity's capital city. Already, the four quadrants of the city had started to take on relatively defined styles of architecture.

Humans tended to live in the north quadrant, above the river. This also happened to be the biggest area, though the western mountain range somewhat cut into the north.

Monsters lived west of the river. They were closest to the western mountains, and many goblins had opted to burrow inside, creating fortified living spaces for themselves.

To the south was a great forest, part of which circled around to the west. Demons lived there, in tree-houses they built using their powers. While demons typically preferred to live in architecture similar to the humans, the ones who aligned with humanity decided to get back in touch with Mother Nature.

Finally, to the east was Melodia's ocean, though a lightly wooded section of the forest cut between Melodia and the great waters. The east was also the quadrant where humans, demons, and monsters intermingled. Melodia's military headquarters had been built at the center of the eastern quadrant, right next to the river.

It was in the eastern section where a funeral procession was being held. A solemn and sad atmosphere pervaded, as nearly all of humanity's top movers and shakers had come. General Chadwick had left Pixiv to visit, and Belial had brought Cassiel and Soleil along as well. Demon Deity Melody sat in the row second from the front, accompanying Belial.

The frontmost row had the unfortunate wife of the deceased. Kiari sat in a chair, her expression stony, her eyes puffy and swollen from crying. Beside her sat Beelzebub, his expression solemn.

There was a podium placed at the front of several hundred seats. Behind it rested Saul's empty coffin; a stark reminder that his body had not been recovered. Despite searching the Hall of Heroes, questioning Chrona, and even looking throughout the

Phoenix's realm, Sharmur, and Pixiv, Saul was nowhere to be found. He had indeed been left behind on Tarus II, and his body had been lost along with so many others.

At the funeral podium, a woman stood with a somber expression. She was humanity's current leader, Linda Adams.

"Saul was a close friend of Neil's, and I know my husband would have been devastated to see him pass. I didn't know Saul as well as I would have liked, but the few times we spoke, I experienced his extraordinary bearing. Like many, Saul was a victim of the machinations of our enemies. Saul was a lover, not a fighter. He kept to himself and lived on the outskirts of society, tending to his garden. He was a good man."

"Saul and my husband had a lot of similarities." Linda continued. "They were both ensnared by Bahamut, albeit for differing reasons. When Jason Hiro released them from their eon of hallucinations, Saul and Neil went different ways. Neil sought revenge, while Saul wished to enjoy peace. I cannot say which one took the more correct path, but I respected both."

"Saul will be missed." Linda concluded. "He leaves behind a wife and child. Like Kiari, I am with child, as are many others. I hope that we as a community can come together to raise the children of so many widowed men and women. Now is the time for us to unite and raise our progeny in a manner that is both forthright and steadfast. Only united can we face our future threats."

Linda tilted her head slightly. She stepped off the podium, allowing the next person to walk up. This turned out to be Beelzebub, who had been asked to speak by Kiari herself. He had been sitting beside Kiari, but eventually stood up and touched her shoulder before walking up to the podium. After taking a moment to collect himself, Beelzebub cleared his throat.

"I am not a good man. I have not been a good man." Beelzebub began. "I have committed atrocities in my life, as have many other demons. Even so, not long after I devastated Tarus II by immolating my body, I awoke to find myself an ordinary human stripped of my power. Through a series of events, I ended up staying with Saul and Kiari for a while."

"They treated me well. Better than I deserved." Beelzebub said somberly, as Kiari dabbed at her puffy red eyes with a handkerchief. "Saul in particular offered me choice words of wisdom on two different occasions. He made me rethink my life choices. He

made me realize that I had been living a lie, and that I was being dishonest with myself. His compassion changed me into the demon I am today. While I still have a long way to go, I am proud to have called him my friend."

"Saul." Beelzebub said, looking up at the sky. "You will be missed."

A moment of silence followed. Beelzebub walked back over and sat beside Kiari again. More people spoke words of remembrance at the podium, numbering two dozen in total. Even Belial gave a short speech.

An hour later, the funeral ended. People came up to Kiari and gave their condolences. Countless people had been MIA, and Saul was ultimately just one of them. But his status as the husband of one of humanity's allied Demon Emperors meant that even people who didn't know him felt the need to at least voice a few words of sympathy.

Eventually, the crowd dissipated. People left, returning to their work in building up the city of Melodia.

Only a dozen or so people remained.

Among them were the demons Kiari, Beelzebub, Belial, and Melody.

Cassiel was there, along with Soleil, albeit in their human disguises of Cammy and Serra. The people who remained behind knew of Cassiel's identity, but none spoke of it. They treated her as an ordinary human, always worrying the demons might find out who she was.

Linda and Debra were also present, along with Chadwick, Henry Cliff, Ashley McCarthy, and even the Minotaur, Yamir Goldenhorn.

"Kiari. How are you holding up?" Chadwick asked.

Kiari stiffened. "I... I'm still... in disbelief. I keep expecting Saul to... to walk through the door. I can't believe he's really dead."

"I feel the same way." Linda said softly. "I always expect to enter my office and see Neil sitting at the desk. He's never there. Unlike you, I at least know for certain that he died. The uncertainty must be the hardest part."

"It is." Kiari admitted quietly.

Belial rubbed Kiari's back reassuringly. "If you ever need anyone to talk to... well, I lost my husband too. I'm always here for you."

"Yeah... thanks..." Kiari muttered. "I'm going to go now. Everyone... thank you for coming. It means so much to me. I'm sure Saul would have..."

She trailed off, not finishing her sentence. Everyone knew what she wanted to say, so it was fine to leave the words unspoken.

After a few more perfunctory words of thanks, Kiari shuffled off, along with Beelzebub. Once the two of them left, the somber atmosphere remained.

"Every day is worse than the last." Linda muttered. "The confirmed death toll so far has been cataclysmic. Families ripped apart, separated between Realspace, the Hall of Heroes, and even the Cube."

Melody crossed her arms. "The situation with the Volgrim isn't great, either. The Dolgrimites have strong-armed the First Founder into becoming a figurehead, and that was just today. They're still shaking the Demon Deities down in a sort of protection racket. They want all of us to bow our heads to Dolgris."

"And if you don't?" Chadwick asked.

"Then they won't offer our worlds any protection. They'll let us die to the Plague. What they want is absolute control over the Milky Way." Melody replied.

"Is this bad news for us?" Yamir asked, crossing his muscled arms.

"Well, it's actually sort of good news." Melody answered. "The Demon Deities are wary of the Volgrim. Even though the Volgrim have lost the overwhelming majority of their Psion fighting force, the Dolgrimites are extremely fearsome. None of the Deities know how the Dolgrimites, as mere mortals, are able to thrash the seemingly invincible Plagueborn. Thus, the Demon Deities are secretly hoping humanity will come up with a countermeasure of our own to push back the Plague."

"Despicable scumbags." Chadwick hissed through his teeth. "They attack us, brutalize us, rape and torture us, and now they expect us to become their saviors? Whatever countermeasures we come up with should be ours and ours alone."

"That's assuming we come up with any at all." Linda pointed out. "I don't know about you, but I haven't heard of anyone working on a countermeasure to the Plague. If we haven't even started, we'll never succeed."

"Don't be so certain!" Belial exclaimed, startling the others. "I know the situation seems dire, what with Jason, Hope, and Phoebe all being dead. But have you people

forgotten?! Fiona is alive and well, inside a time-accelerated realm. Every day we hold on, another year passes for her. She's inventive, resourceful, and smart as hell. She'll definitely come up with a solution to the Plague."

"Don't count out the Hall of Heroes." Henry said, jumping into the conversation with both feet. "Solomon might be dead, but we have many powerful ancient Heroes at work trying to solve the same problem. Hope's kids, especially Mandy, have serious potential to disrupt the galactic balance of power. Mandy has been experimenting with Rune Words to try and eradicate the infection that turns Plaguehosts into faceless monsters."

"Any success?" Melody asked.

"...Not as of yet." Henry admitted. "But all it takes is one lucky breakthrough. If the Dolgrimites can uncover the Plague's weakness, humanity can as well."

A moment passed. Cassiel decided to speak up, which surprised everyone. She usually stayed quiet so as to not blow her cover, shaky though it might be.

"Didn't Jason cure the Flaw? Why have no humans become Heroes yet?"

Linda blinked. She looked at Cassiel thoughtfully.

"A good question. I'm not sure. Perhaps repairing the Flaw wasn't enough? Maybe we're all too old and it will only affect our children, years from now?"

"Plausible..." Belial said quietly. "We don't have any way to know. For now, increasing the Legion's size is probably our best bet."

"The more people who become Legion, the more our collective base of knowledge improves." Henry added. As the foremost Legion representative, he was always eager to advertise its benefits. "We're not just fighters, you know. We have scientists and inventors among our ranks. We're even trying to bring a few Heroic Ancestors into the fold. With Solomon dead, we need all the help we can get."

Despite his excitement, Henry's pitch didn't move the hearts of anyone present. The Legion was looked upon favorably for the strength of its members, but everyone who wanted to join its hivemind already had. Anyone who hadn't joined yet were unlikely to do so in the near future.

Despite being called 'Legion', it only had around 3,000 soldiers. Each member was strong, but the quality of its soldiers varied widely. Henry was the strongest, and he was able to contend with Demon Emperors. None of the others were in his league. That

indicated further additions to the Legion would likely only be in the range of Demon Lord strength. Not worth it for the price of giving up one's entire private life, as far as most humans were concerned.

"I don't see that happening." Linda said to Belial, after noting the muted response to Henry's plea. "Humans are strong because we embrace technology and magic equally and without bias. I would like to focus on empowering Samantha, Kiari, and our other high-level assets with technology rather than moderately uplifting the strength of our weakest assets. A thousand ants cannot bring down an elephant."

"If our enemies were only the Plaguehosts, that would be true." Chadwick countered. "But humanity must beware the Volgrim and Demons just as much."

The small group continued to talk for a while longer, but they didn't come to much of a consensus. Eventually, they dispersed and went their separate ways.

As Belial left, Cassiel and Soleil jogged over to her side.

"Hey." Cassiel said with a small smile. "Um, can we do more training? That funeral left me feeling... restless."

Belial nodded. "I suppose."

The trio started walking toward the northern side of Melodia. They crossed one of its central river bridges and made their way up to the woodlands. There they entered a makeshift arena hidden in the forest that Belial and Cassiel had carved with their magical abilities.

Cassiel looked around. She confirmed there weren't any demons or other Sentients in the area, then she deactivated the Heaven's Shroud. Her true angelic form emerged, a halo above her white hair, her wings spilling out behind her back.

Belial looked at her, then quickly looked away.

"Is something wrong?" Cassiel asked.

Belial hesitated. "It's just... for a second there, I was a little struck by your..."

She trailed off.

"My what?" Cassiel asked.

Belial shook her head. "Nothing. It's nothing. Let's get to training. You've been improving a lot over the last two weeks, but you're still a long way from beating me."

Cassiel nodded. She focused her mind, then rapidly conjured a set of powerful divine armor around herself, completely hiding her body within its confines. After donning this armor, she stood nearly seven feel tall and towered over Belial. She wielded a heavy great-mace in her right hand, and a tower shield in her left.

Soleil stood at the edge of the arena, not watching Cassiel, but instead monitoring the area. She was always aware and fearful of the idea Gressil could suddenly attack. Having fought Belial a couple of times, Soleil had confirmed her physical body was on par with a Demon Emperor. She could absolutely beat Gressil if he showed his face, which was likely why he hadn't.

The Black Hole Construct was Cassiel's protector, assigned to her by the fallen Jason Hiro. She took her duties seriously. With Cassiel spending more time with Belial over the last couple of weeks, Soleil had felt that her friendship with her master had taken a hit. She and Cassiel simply didn't talk as much anymore, and not as closely when they did. Cassiel's trauma had noticeably faded, replaced instead with a hunger and resolve to become stronger.

Cassiel's ultimate goal was apparent. She wanted to become strong enough to take revenge on her tormentor with her own hands. No matter the price, she wanted to flay Gressil's skin from his body, piece by piece.

Thus, she was only relying on Soleil in the present, while she still needed to. Cassiel was not happy with her own weakness, but she had to make do with the resources at her disposal.

"Begin!" Belial shouted as she lunged at Cassiel.

The world of Numaria.

Yardrat's Astral Body stepped through one of his portals into a treehouse high in the woodlands of Numaria. He arrived inside Demon Deity Auger's palace, then immediately took a knee while bowing his head.

"Master, I have returned. The Dolgrimite delegates were persistent."

Auger stepped out of a nearby room where he had been freshening up. The wise old male demon smiled at his subordinate.

"Dangerous, these zealot types are. We can continue delaying them for a time, but eventually, they will demand an answer. They know our delays are intentional, and we know they know, but still we must maintain the facade. They intend to crush our morale when the humans fail to come up with a counter-measure against the Plague."

"Master, we already had a counter-measure." Yardrat said, lifting his head to look up at Yardrat. "Diablo. If one of us could rise to defeat the Plague, could not another?"

Auger sighed. "If Diablo had joined with me, I could have gained access to the power of the so-called Archdemon. Then his death would not have affected us materially. I would have passed his ability on to another before he perished, be they you or someone else. But do not forget, Yardrat, that it was the empowered Plague which defeated the Archdemon. Perhaps the Archdemon's power was only effective against the Plague's former, weaker iteration."

A few moments passed. Yardrat stood up, then looked off into the distance while chewing his lower lip.

"It occurs to me that we do not necessarily need to 'defeat' the Plague, master. We need only make it disappear. Perhaps by using my portals, we could send the Kolvaxors far, far away. To another galaxy, even. With their strongest entities gone, the Plague would not be able to press the attack so easily."

"Can your portals reach that far?" Auger asked pointedly.

Another several seconds passed. Yardrat knotted his brow and concentrated, sending out his Cosmic power to the edge of the Milky Way. He gave up not long afterward.

"...No. The Akashic Barrier limits me. If it were that easy, other entities with powers similar to mine could have- huh?"

At the same time, Yardrat and Auger suddenly lifted their heads. They looked up toward the ceiling, not actually looking at it, but gazing through its physical form as if it didn't exist.

"A Cosmic Signature entering the Numaria system?" Auger exclaimed. "We're not expecting guests! And this speed... who could it be?"

"It's heading straight for our world, master!" Yardrat replied. "I shall intercept."

"No, don't." Auger said. "You are but a Low Cosmic, tethered to Yardris. Your power is limited while off-world. I must be the one to investigate this newcomer's intentions!"

Auger waved his hand, and a hole opened in the ceiling. An instant later, he rocketed upward, traveling into Numaria's upper atmosphere within just a few seconds. His speed was ludicrous. He caused a sonic boom due to his excessive speed.

But the approaching entity made his heart turn cold.

"Impossible... a High Cosmic?! Such a creature does not exist in the Milky Way! Unless... have the Dolgrimites grown more serious? Could their master be...?"

The blip of energy raced toward Numaria, drawing closer and closer every second. Auger had sensed it once it arrived at the furthest edge of the system, but it had already crossed half the distance to Numaria, traveling dozens of AU in mere moments.

"A High Cosmic..." Auger whispered, frightened out of his wits.

If the entity held any hostile intentions, he would not be able to resist. The combined power of all the Middle Cosmic Deities might stand a chance, but they could only project limited fragments of their power via weakened Astral Bodies or through Yardrat's portals. They could not unite together to defend any individual system. This was demonkind's greatest weakness!

Worse, if an enemy did kill one of the Demon Deities, they could never replace the fallen. Only Diablo possessed the power to Uplift his brethren. Each dead Deity would be a permanent loss to their empire!

"Damn, damn, damn! Just who is it?" Auger hissed, readying himself for a battle. "The aura feels a little familiar, but there's such a dense veil of hatred and bloodlust, it makes me want to vomit! This creature is an aberration, without fail!"

Auger was tempted to abandon his world, but that would effectively mean suicide. He was a Middle Cosmic and had been tethered to Numaria permanently. If he left, he would become a Demon Grunt again, losing all his powers and abilities. If the star was destroyed, he would die.

"Come on then. We'll see if my arsenal can defeat your superior strength!" Auger roared.

Less than a minute after entering the system, the incoming High Cosmic was within sight. Auger's battle rage shifted. His eyes widened as he beheld the figure hurtling toward him.

"You... how could it be.. no! My world! Watch out!!"

The figure blew past Auger at a speed too incomprehensible to put into words. It crashed into Numaria's atmosphere and instantly lit up the world's forests, sending walls of flames blasting outward in all directions from the impact site. A shockwave of unimaginable proportions detonated in a sphere, flattening forests, causing mountains to erupt in parallel with the shockwave's momentum, and the oceans to tear away from the land. Later, they would crash back upon the shores, summoning hundred-foot-tall tsunamis to ravage the coasts.

The figure burned on impact. It appeared not to be in control of its flight, and was instead falling helplessly toward the planet below, its flight slowing down every second due to extreme friction.

Forest fires swept outward in the path of the falling Cosmic. Demons and monsters perished en-masse, opening their mouths to scream, only for their bodies to instantly immolate and evaporate to ash. Even hardy Demon Barons could barely withstand the force of the falling Cosmic for mere seconds before they, too, were dispatched to the Great Beyond.

Eventually, the figure crashed into a mountain, sending millions of tons of rock and debris flying in a great cone outward. Those walls of debris rained down upon Numaria's forest, smashing into trees and breaking them into splinters and fragments of wood.

A minute later, it was over. The aftereffects of the Cosmic's fall would cause immense damage to Numaria over the coming weeks, devastating it with fires and flame... but the planet had ultimately survived, even if only barely.

Auger flew down and stopped half a kilometer above the crash side. He swallowed short, sharp breaths as he glowered with hate-filled eyes.

"Show yourself, woman! You dare come here, thinking I will be an easy target? This decapitation strike will fail! It will be your head I claim today!"

The figure lay deep inside an underground chasm, one carved by their fall to Numaria. After several seconds, nobody responded, leaving Auger more worried than before.

"Come out!" He barked. "Or else!"

A voice spoke from deep underground. The voice was weak, as if heavily injured. It was also male.

"**Auger. Come... down here... it is... not... she... it is me...**"

Auger blinked. "What? How can that be?"

He carefully flew downward, using the powers of multiple Burrowers amplified to the Cosmic level to carve a path to the Cosmic signature that lay unmoving beneath the mountain.

Eventually, Auger arrived. He found a figure covered in black armor, soaked in blood, laying face-down amidst the rubble. The figure was badly injured and looked to be on the brink of death.

"Auger... help me..."

Auger took three steps forward. He stopped at arm's length away and looked at the broken man who lay before him.

"Barbatos? You're... you're alive? But Uriel possessed you. She was taken! Taken by the Plague!"

Barbatos, the former Duke of Steel, now possessed a body on the level of a High Cosmic. He was a Demon Deity stronger than any other. But he was also dying.

The Deity named Barbatos coughed blood. He carefully turned his head, his dim red eyes looking up at Auger with eyes that did not yet wish to die.

"A plot... most foul... a trap... we were fooled... the Milky Way... she... she will kill us... her hatred... infinite... her revenge... she... she... *she*..."

The breath left his body. He fainted, unable to complete what he was saying.

Auger stared in bewilderment at Barbatos's broken form. He gazed upon it for all of three seconds before quickly and gently levitating him into the air.

"I must find Belial! AT ONCE!!"

Part 692: Healing Barbatos

Far-Future Era. Noon, Day 20, AJR. Melodia.

Cassiel's massive armored form moved far too quickly for how heavy and cumbersome it looked. She flapped her wings and lunged at Belial, swinging a greatmace made of light at her as if it were a toothpick. When Belial leaped to the side to evade, the mace struck the ground and sprayed a cone of dirt out in a huge circle. In truth, the mace was a weapon so heavy that no human could lift it even an inch off the ground, yet Cassiel defied this rule not because of her bodily strength, but because the mace was formed of light energy she could control with her mind.

She cheated the laws of physics!

Her armor was the same. Though it was made from 'mere' strands of holy energy, it was tougher than demonstone, with an intricate internal structure that absorbed the impact of blunt blows and resisted the impaling strikes of sharp weapons.

Belial's fingers turned into claws of bone. Her arm snapped out and stretched, raking Cassiel's armor as she tried to grab onto any gaps in the armor and rip it apart piece by piece. She failed. The armor was too seamless, and her efforts left only the shallowest of scratches on the armor's surface, scratches which immediately vanished as the armor healed itself with Cassiel's internal energy.

A brutal and fast-paced melee commenced. Cassiel sometimes chased Belial and tried to kill her (within reason) while other times Belial's brutal strength struck Cassiel and sent her flying! Her armor might be hard and her mace capable of inflicting great pain upon an adversary, but Belial was a living weapon. She had strength greater than Bael in his prime, the ability to heal herself, and ways of stretching her body to evade attacks with unnatural dexterity. By comparison, Cassiel's heavy armor was a giant target she could not use to evade with much ease.

Deep and heavy footprints had sunk into the ground around the arena. Cassiel's 7-foot-tall armored form stomped the pavement with brutal force, leaving imprints deep enough for a fully-grown-man to feel inadequate if her were to step into them. These also created a slight tripping hazard, which turned into Cassiel's undoing! She stormed toward Belial to try and deliver a final attack, but her foot half-stepped into a deep groove she

had left previously, and this was enough to make her lose her footing. Cassiel cried out as she tumbled forward and fell face-first to the ground, momentarily stunned.

Belial leaped on top of her back, stretched her arms and legs around Cassiel's armored limbs, and began to constrict her like a cobra.

"Submit!" Belial shouted.

"I won't! Uaaahh!" Cassiel roared.

She struggled mightily, but being able to somewhat manipulate the laws of physics by altering the weight of her equipment was nothing compared to Belial's vastly superior strength. If Belial were wearing the armor, she would move and attack even faster, since she was a far stronger entity!

After a few seconds, Cassiel's armor started to groan in protest. She wriggled and wiggled, trying to break free of the spiderweb-like stretchy limbs that bound her, but she failed to break free.

Thirty seconds later, her body went still. Cassiel sighed.

"...I concede."

Belial smiled. "That wasn't so hard, was it?"

She unwound herself from around Cassiel's limbs, then hopped off the armor, allowing Cassiel to de-summon it. Cassiel looked tired and glum from losing to Belial again.

"Why can't I beat you?" Cassiel asked while plopping on her butt and staring at the ground. "I'm so weak now."

"You're not weak at all." Belial said, as she took a seat next to Cassiel and gently massaged her back. She'd been doing that a lot, recently. "I'm just a bad matchup for you. I have tens of millennia of fighting experience, my body is much stronger than yours, and I also know exactly how your powers work. I can counter you much more easily now."

"How strong are you compared to Emperor Crow?" Cassiel pressed.

"Hmm..." Belial hummed, looking off into the distance. "I'm not entirely certain. The last time I fought Crow was during the Energy Wars as part of a mock exercise."

"So you don't know how strong she is?" Cassiel pressed.

"I do. Sort of. But only vaguely." Belial answered. "Crow is known as the most physically powerful Emperor. Her physical strength is likely higher than mine, and her

durability was considered close to Bael's, so in terms of taking and dealing damage, she's a powerhouse. However, her defense is overstated. She's durable because of her feathers, which are harder than demonstone. They form a powerful set of natural armor around herself, and they can be launched and controlled remotely."

Cassiel appeared intrigued. "Like drones?"

"Sure. Like drones." Belial confirmed. "But if I were to seriously go against Crow, it's not clear which of us would win. I'm much more agile than Crow, and good at avoiding damage. I can stretch my body and move in unnatural ways, allowing me to feint hard against my enemies. I can heal myself and my allies, but Crow cannot. If push came to shove, I could enter my True Succubus form, and I would probably be on par with her physically."

"True Succubus form?" Cassiel said, trying to imagine what that would look like in her head.

"I harden my skin to stone, grow a pair of wings, and my defensive ability rises sharply." Belial explained. "But I can't heal or stretch my limbs while in that form, so there's a tradeoff."

To emphasize her point, Belial changed her body shape. Her skin turned dark grey, with a rocky texture covering it, and stone wings growing out of her back. Cassiel's eyes glinted with awe.

"That's your True Succubus form?"

Belial shook her head. "No. I just shapeshifted to look like it. Changing my form is exhausting and leaves me vulnerable once I revert. It's a measure of last resort, and doesn't always work. I used it against Ose during Stormbringer, but I still lost."

Cassiel seemed to understand. She nodded.

"So do you think if I fought Emperor Crow, I could win?"

"Why the fixation on Crow?" Belial asked. "Of all the Emperors?"

"Because I killed Emperor Red Raven." Cassiel said softly. "Of all the demons who exist, I imagine none hate me more than Crow. I ran into her inside the Core a couple of weeks ago. Luckily, she didn't notice my Heaven's Shroud. If she had, I'd probably have died without being able to protect myself."

Belial deeply frowned. "If that's the case, then we have to be more careful. We cannot allow your identity to leak. I should look into building an underground training area- or perhaps we should contact the Phoenix. Training in a slightly time-accelerated realm will give us more privacy. I'm sure Henry will have a few Legionnaires inside the Cube."

At this point, the Cube had become humanity's worst-kept secret. The demons knew of its existence, as did the Volgrim, but locating it was impossible, at least for the moment. With Tarus II destroyed, the Cube had departed the system, and none could locate it through any means below the Cosmic. It was hidden inside a dimensional tunnel, and the one entity capable of sensing it, Founder Dosena, had lost her powers.

"You're probably right." Cassiel said. "Of the two, I think the Cube would be the best-"

"Incoming!" Soleil suddenly shouted, startling Cassiel and Belial both. "A Cosmic Energy signature just appeared at the Warpgate. It's a Demon Deity!"

Her senses toward this sort of thing were even superior to Belial's. By the time Belial would have sensed the Demon Deity's approach, it would have been too late.

Cassiel immediately grabbed her Heaven's Shroud. She morphed her body back into that of an ordinary human, then hurriedly tucked the shroud into her shirt. At the same time, Soleil shifted her form to a human woman and took a seat on the ground, lounging casually as if unaware of what was coming.

Moments later, an Astral Body tore across the sky at ludicrous speed. It locked on to Belial's position, then rushed toward her before abruptly stopping less than ten meters away.

The newcomer was a woman wearing black robes tightly winding around her body. Her pitch-black eyes glowed with the light of the Void. She was Vespera, the Demon Deity of Quasars.

"Belial!" Vespera said, as she levitated before the succubus. "You must come with me. At once!"

Belail stood up. She glowered at Vespera. "And why would that be? This is Melody's world. You dare not try to kidnap me here."

"It is a matter of great importance." Vespera replied. "We require your healing powers. The situation is dire!"

"Whoever it is, just throw them in the Blood Pits." Belial said, crossing her arms. "I'm not your personal nurse."

"You do not understand the gravity of the situation." Vespera hissed. She levitated closer to Belial and lowered her voice. "The one who needs healing is a Demon Deity. The wounds he suffered will affect our ability to fight off the Plague. It is in both our best interests to help him."

Belial blinked. Her posture softened a little. "Who was injured?"

"I cannot say. Not here, not publicly." Vespera answered. She suddenly glanced at Soleil, then at Cassiel, as if noticing the presence of two bugs crawling on the wall for the first time. Her gaze especially lingered on Cassiel, due to her proximity to Belial. She was standing right next to her.

"These two are my maidservants." Belial said. "Anything you can say to me, you can say in front of them."

"They are human. They are not worthy." Vespera spat, before returning her attention to Belial. "Now hurry and come along. Or would you rather allow a close friend to perish due to your obstinance?"

"A close friend?" Belial repeated, her heart suddenly chilling a couple of degrees. "Who?"

Vespera sneered. "Are you coming, or not?"

Belial hesitated for another few seconds before her obstinance visibly deflated. She nodded. "Alright. Take me there, then. Cammy, Serra, I'll return later."

Cassiel and Soleil nodded respectfully, then bowed at the waist.

"Yes, mistress." Cassiel said, playing up the part of an uneducated servant girl. "We will await your return."

Belial nodded gruffly, then allowed Vespera to grab hold of her with Void energy and levitate her into the air.

Before they departed, Vespera glanced at Cassiel. "I didn't take you as the type to use servants, Belial."

"It's Samantha." Belial immediately replied. "And I have my... *needs*... that my girls fulfill. It's none of your business."

"Ohoho, so it's like that?" Vespera sneered. She took off into the air, but for a brief instant, a sensation of shock went through her body as her powerful Cosmic sense casually scanned Cassiel and Soleil one last time. She immediately closed her mouth and steadied her expression. Belial didn't notice the anomaly.

The two of them rocketed away. After they left, Cassiel frowned, ever so slightly.

Vespera took Belial to the Warpgate, which brought them to the Core. After that, they transferred to Numaria, and this immediately raised alarm bells for Belial. After all, the Deity of Numaria was Auger! Had he been struck by an enemy? And if so, who?

"It's not Auger." Vespera said, quieting the voices in Belial's head. "Remain patient. You will see."

If Belial was being honest with herself, she found it rather obnoxious how Vespera, a young upstart who became a Deity through a stroke of luck, lorded her presence over Belial. When Belial fought the angels in the Ancient Era, Vespera was not even spawned yet. When the Energy Wars raged, Vespera was little more than a Baron on the frontlines. Belial was thousands of years older than her, but Vespera acted like she wore britches too big for Belial to comprehend.

It was truly irritating.

The two women flew quickly through the sky. Belial's eyes widened in horror as she saw that the world of Numaria was on fire as far as her eyes could see. Much of the forest had been flattened. Infernos raged, and the few demons who specialized in water magic had been assigned to Numaria to try and put out all the burning trees.

Soon, they drew close to a mountain, one which looked like it had once been tall and fearsome, but now was shattered and broken. Belial could tell with a single glance that something had crashed into and destroyed the mountain. It was probably 1/5th its original size, with a massive impact tunnel leading deep into Numaria's underbelly.

Vespera took Belial underground. She set Belial down and gestured ahead with her chin. "Follow me. Move quickly!"

Belial nodded. The two of them started running through the somewhat narrowed corridor at the speeds only high level demons could achieve, and within less than a minute, they drew closer and closer to an aura so powerful and suffocating that Belial

started to feel afraid. Whatever was down here, it dwarfed the aura of Auger, which she had sensed many times since his ascension.

Finally, they arrived inside a cavern that had been deliberately hollowed out. Several demons, none of them below the rank of Emperor, stood waiting as Belial appeared.

Emperor Crow was standing at the back, nearest the entrance, and was the first to say something when Belial emerged inside the room. "Ca-CAW! Took you long enough! Hurry! He's dying!"

"Belial, over here!" Yardrat shouted, his astral body levitating a few feet off the ground.

Belial walked further into the cave and approached a body that was immediately familiar to her.

"Uriel?! She's alive??" Belial asked, bewildered.

Auger appeared at Belial's side. He squeezed her shoulder reassuringly.

"Not Uriel. This is Barbatos. Pure and simple. Somehow, he has regained control of his body while also ascending to the rank of High Cosmic. I need not tell you what a fortuitous outcome this is for demonkind, but we must know what happened and how he escaped the clutches of the Plague. He passed out before he could tell me. Heal him, Samantha. I beg of you!"

Belial nodded. Barbatos was a good demon. He was slow to anger, and absolutely worthy of being the highest ranked among their people. Even if Uriel took over again, Belial felt that Uriel had changed a lot after spending time with the humans. She might not go on a genocidal rampage.

"Where is Serena?" Belial asked. "I can heal the body, but if he has any injuries to his soul..."

"No worries." Yardrat said. "I'm already bringing Serena and Leeroy here. The two of them should be able to help you recover Barbatos's energy."

And so, with that in mind, Belial got to work. Dozens of powerful Demon Emperors and Deities watched from the sidelines, whispering to one another while she concentrated and started working to heal him.

Unbeknownst to her, Vespera had moved more to the back of the room. A deep frown was playing upon her face. She massaged her chin repeatedly, muttering under her breath with signs of obvious agitation.

"Vespera." Demon Emperor Hamir whispered. "Is something the matter?"

"Perhaps..." Vespera whispered, before lowering her voice even further. "When I picked up Belial, I made a distressing discovery. She had two humans in her entourage, but one of them appeared to be wearing a Heaven's Shroud."

"What? A Shroud? You're certain?" Hamir asked.

Another nearby demon perked her ears up. Emperor Crow subtly turned her gaze to look at Vespera. She kept quiet, listening while pretending not to hear their discussion.

"Someone named 'Cammy.'" Vespera said, her voice shaking. "That was her human name, at least."

"Cammy?" Hamir asked. "As in... Camael? Is it possible?"

"So many other Archangels have survived, perhaps the old witch herself did, too." Vespera said. "I will speak to Auger of this matter soon. The only reason I didn't immediately make a move was because if she was indeed Camael in disguise, she could pose a threat to me, especially my mere Astral Body. Also, that world is Melody's stronghold. I wouldn't want to draw her attention."

"No, you made the right choice." Hamir whispered, gently touching her arm. The two of them hailed from the same Hell and had known each other for millennia. They were intimately close. "We now know to look for a human named 'Cammy'. What is her human appearance?"

Vespera described Cassiel's shouded look, and Hamir nodded seriously. "A brown-haired young woman and her black-haired friend... I don't imagine Camael would appear young, but perhaps she altered and improved upon the original Heaven's Shroud. It would certainly make us suspect her less, and explain how she evaded capture all these millennia."

"If Camael is alive, do you think this has anything to do with Barbatos reappearing here and Uriel now seemingly dormant?"

"I am not certain." Vespera admitted. "All of this is quite... worrying. I sense a grand plot may be at play."

While she and Hamir continued to swap theories, Emperor Crow's breathing became irregular. She looked around, realizing nobody was paying any attention to her. Auger

would certainly want to make a speech about Barbatos's survival later, but that wasn't of any importance to Crow.

It's her. It's that angel I found in the simulation. Not Camael. Heaven's Daughter! The one who killed my HUSBAND!

Flames of rage erupted inside Crow's mind. It became more and more difficult for her to contain her smoldering craving for vengeance.

"Yo! Crow! You good, sister?"

Crow turned to see Emperor Fae standing a short distance away, looking at her with a smug smirk.

"I am... fine." Crow hissed. "I believe my last ritual imbalanced my mana. Excuse me. I must depart."

"Sure, whatever!" Fae laughed. "I'll let Old Man Auger know!"

"Please do." Crow said.

She turned and stormed away. Only Fae knew she had left. Belial was completely unaware.

As she left, Crow thought of several things.

It will take Belial time to heal Barbatos. He is a powerful Cosmic. Her mortal magic will be ineffective compared to its usual potency. Additionally, Auger will want to bluster about the so-called fate of demonkind, thus keeping Belial even longer. I have a window of opportunity before she can return to that angel's side.

Crow stepped out into the smoking Numarian hellscape. She flapped her wings and leaped into the sky, taking flight as she raced back to the Warpgate.

Heaven's Daughter! Your life is MINE!

* * *

At the same time, sweat dripped from Belial's forehead. She wiped it off and breathed heavily.

"The wounds are severe." Belial grunted. "I'm healing Barbatos, but the progress is slow. I haven't sensed any holy energy inside of him. Maybe Uriel isn't inside his soul anymore."

"Or she's gone dormant." Auger retorted. "It fits the pattern."

"Maybe, but then again, maybe not." Belial countered. "Auger, is there even *one* entity in the Milky Way that could maim Barbatos this brutally? Notice how powerful he has become. He looks like he took on a group of equally powerful enemies and barely survived by the skin of his teeth."

"An Apex Cosmic would be capable of bringing Barbatos to this state." Auger confirmed. "But such an enemy would be more likely to kill him. I just don't know... once you heal him, we'll hear the full story."

Belial nodded. She doubled her efforts, straining mightily as her pitiful mortal magic slowly put together the much tougher, much more vitality-filled bones, tendons, and blood-veins that comprised Barbatos's body.

Two entire hours passed. Leeroy and Serena soon arrived, helping Belial heal the other components of Barbatos's injuries, namely his brain and soul. Eventually, Barbatos stirred. He was far from fully healed, but he had enough vitality to rouse himself.

"Uhh..." Barbatos wheezed.

"Brother Barbatos." Auger said, dropping to one knee while resting a palm on Barbatos's chest. "How are you faring?"

The former Duke of Steel slowly opened his eyes. They were now glowing bright red, but still had an aura of weakness to them. It was clear he was far from well.

"Fooled..." Barbatos said weakly. "We were tricked. My brother... Artorias... he... he was..."

"Artorias?" Belial asked. "What about him? What happened?"

Barbatos slowly closed his eyes. His breathing became shallower.

For a time, nobody said a word. They started to think their sole High Cosmic had fallen back into a coma.

But then, with his eyes closed, he began to speak.

"Raphael... it was.. him... his plot..."

And so, Barbatos began to narrate the fate that had befallen him.

His story would contain a shocking tale that upended everyone's knowledge of the galactic order.

They had all of them... *been deceived*.

Part 693: Creator's Conspiracy

Far-Future Era. Two days pre-AJR.

Two 7th Level Kolvaxors gazed down upon Uriel as she was dragged under the soil.

"Raph-!!"

Dirt flooded into Uriel's mouth, choking her and burying alive. The last thing she saw was her brother's silent, unmoving figure.

* * *

Time passed.

Uriel awoke in a daze. Her vision blurry, she couldn't make out the world around herself.

Then, all at once, a spike of fear shot through her heart. Her eyes widened, and her vision cleared up. She found herself in an unbelievably vast underground chasm, embedded in a wall. Less than twenty feet ahead of her, on the opposite wall, there were strange objects snared in place. It took her a second to identify them as strange webbed pods. The sort of thing a giant spider would use to ensnare a meal and wrap it up before consuming it later. Uriel tried to move, to wiggle her body, but she failed.

Her heart-rate shot up further as she looked down and realized she, too, was trapped! Only her head was free, which stood in contrast to the other webbed pods that clung to the walls. A look to her right and left demonstrated that there were thousands, hundreds of thousands, perhaps millions of other pods going up, down, left and right, as far as her powerful eyesight could see. The chasm seemed to extended infinitely into the distance, a dense fog blanketing the far distant edges.

"Nay, nay, nay!" Uriel cried, trying even harder to wiggle. She failed again. "What devilry... nay!!"

Her arms were fastened against her stomach. They were completely ensnared by webs with the consistency of iron and concrete. She couldn't twitch a finger, let alone cast magic to try and free herself. Even her toes were trapped. She realized she had been stripped nude, and now only her head was free! Her hair was filthy, and it clung to the

webbing, making it so if she turned her head too much, she was certain to rip some of her hairs out. A mild pain she would gladly endure if it ensured her survival.

She was not truly herself. She had long ago possessed Barbatos's body and reformed it in her image. She looked just like her original self, but at her core, she had corrupted the body of a Demon Duke, forcibly empowering it to the peak of mortal power.

Now, she felt that, though she could not see her body, she knew something had changed. That facade was failing her. Her hair, what little she saw, had lost its white color and had turned black. When she screamed, her voice was deeper and more masculine. She was reverting back to Barbatos's original form! Whatever this pod was, it was undoing all her hard work to return to her original appearance.

But she didn't care about that. She would happily wear Barbatos's body like a puppet so long as it allowed her to escape and achieve her objectives. Right now, she was most horrified by the fact this strange webbed pod *had* such a power. Was it draining her energy? Was it going to suck the life from her soul? Was she-

[Sister. Thou art finally awake.]

A male voice spoke within Uriel's soul. She quickly submerged herself into her Mind Realm, where she found Raphael, Michael, and Gabriel all awaiting her arrival.

When Uriel's spirit manifested next to her brothers, she immediately locked eyes with Raphael. He smiled kindly at her, but she felt a chill go down her back. Neither Michael nor Gabriel said a word. They stared at the ground, as if having recently learned a secret that had... shattered their spirits.

[Raphael! RAPHAEL!] Uriel roared. [Thou hath explaining to do!]

She stormed toward Raphael and grabbed him by his robes' collar, but he didn't resist. His smile weakened, and he looked off to the side.

[Sister. Many millennia have passed, but the Work is done. Do not fret. The current situation is not as it appears. You are safe.]

[Safe?!] Uriel bit back. [I'm trapped! Trapped in a strange, horrible room made of nightmares! Art thou behind this??]

[Indeed, I am.] Raphael admitted. He fell silent, before adding, [Release me, and I shalt answer all the questions on thy mind.]

Uriel flicked her eyes over to Gabriel and Michael, but she didn't let Raphael go. Upon sensing her gaze, Michael lifted his head and locked eyes with her.

[Listen to Raphael's tale.] Michael said quietly. ['Tis both horrifying and beautiful. But mostly... tragic. He has long planned for this day to come.]

Uriel's eyebrows tensed. She continued to squeeze Raphael's collar, lifting him off the ground an inch or two before snarling and dropping him back on his feet. She spun around and walked a few steps away to cool her head.

[Speak!] Uriel barked. [What treachery is this?! One of the Kolvaxians which struck me was an illusion, an illusion made by THEE! I saw it with my own eyes, Raphael!]

['Twas, and thou dids't.] Raphael admitted. [Sister, come, sit. I have already explained the situation to Michael and Gabriel. 'Tis time thou understood the Truth I hath not spoken in my life. Only one other knows, but Solomon wisely kept his mouth shut, as this Truth did not concern him.]

Uriel relented. She walked over to Raphael, but even as he took a seat, she did not. A feeling of uncertainty had taken hold, and she now felt she couldn't trust her own brother. As such, she merely stood with her arms crossed, looking down on his seated form.

Raphael didn't press the issue. He summoned a pipe and started to smoke.

['Twas many eons ago when I first conceived my plan. Many roadblocks barred the path. I needed to systematically eliminate them, one by one.]

[It began with the Dragon and Titan Wars. Primordial battles which occurred on a scale few can begin to fathom. Wars which obliterated entire star systems and ravaged the galaxy, slowly but surely draining it of its magical energy. And with that drainage, the weakness of the Angel form became apparent.]

Raphael stayed quiet for a time.

[The Creator. 'Twas I who killed him.]

[What?!] Uriel gasped. [Thy father fell at thine hand?!]

[Indeed he did.] Raphael said quietly. [He made me in his image. He expended all his power to ensure I was his equal. At the moment he finished, he had already lost the qualifications to be our galaxy's Ruler. I did not kill him immediately, but instead, a few million years after he had created me and taught me the virtues he lived by.]

Raphael continued. [I killed my father because I believed that by doing so, I would become Ruler. I was wrong. I failed to ascend. And that in turn led to my concocting of wild plans, one after another, schemes I believed that would allow me to Ascend. All of them failed.]

Uriel gazed at her brother with the eyes of someone spotting a beast lurking in the darkness. She was not a fool. She had seen flashes of his cunning, glimpses of the monstrous side he had tried to hide, but never did she realize the depths of his depravity.

[And this latest scheme?] Uriel asked. [Trapping us in a den of evil?!]

[Ah. This plan is one I began working on even before I had our people's minds wiped.] Raphael explained. [Camael gave me the idea. A method to make the angels regain their sovereign status once again. Unfortunately, the price we need pay would be... quite extreme.]

Raphael gestured broadly outside of Uriel's vision.

[The time is now, sister. Our people await.]

Uriel blinked. [Our people...?]

She returned her attention to the real world. What she saw scared the life out of her.

She was no longer inside that terrible chasm. She had been freed! Without her even knowing, the pod that ensnared her had vanished, and she had somehow been transported to a pure white realm that shone with blinding light. Her eyes watered from its luminosity. She attempted to shield her face with her hands, but the light came equally from all directions and cast no shadows. It was a futile effort.

"This... where is this place?" Uriel asked.

Raphael materialized beside her, his body the same spiritual construct as before.

"'Tis the Cosmic Realm, sister. Or perhaps, one mayeth say 'tis the shoddy facsimile of the True Cosmic Realm I tried to create. Sadly, I failed and could not subvert Akasha's domain... but this False Cosmic Realm still has its uses."

Raphael smiled at Uriel. She did not smile back. She shivered, feeling there was something uncanny about his expression.

"Fear not, Uriel. This day is one I hath long awaited." Raphael said slowly. "Look around thyself. Sense the energy in the air. Hath thou failed to notice what makes this

Cosmic Realm unique?"

Uriel tore her eyes away from Raphael. She tried to sense something, anything, but all she could feel was the presence of that all-encompassing light which even her Archangel senses could not block out.

"What am I supposed to sense?" Uriel questioned.

"Ah... verily, thy soul manipulation hath always been inferior to those of the other Archangels." Raphael said with a shake of his head. "I assumed thousands of years battling the will of those two pitiful demons would have improved thy soul sense, but alas."

He gestured broadly.

"This Cosmic Realm failed in its original purpose. But later, I repurposed it to become a repository... a repository of fallen souls. Every Pureblooded Angel who hath fallen since the ancient times ultimately came to reside here. The only exceptions were those whose souls were permanently extinguished, those whose souls were captured by malevolent actors, such as Satan the Devil... and we Archangels, who ultimately took up abode within our rings."

"What?" Uriel questioned, her pupils shrinking to pinpricks. "This... this cannot be! Is not that the same function as the ancient Lazarus Tower, albeit focused upon the souls of angels instead of the souls of humans?!"

Raphael smiled at her slyly.

"How dost thou thinketh I came upon the idea for the Tower? My Cosmic Realm was the original creation, and the Lazarus Tower was but a weaker, modified recreation."

Uriel stared at him blankly for a time. Then, her expression became intense.

"The Lazarus Tower had a flaw, Raphael! Thou were only able to succeed in making it function properly by sacrificing Michael's life to bind all of humanity to the tower. But in order to capture the far mightier souls of angels, particularly ancient angels, an even greater sacrifice would have been necessary!!"

Raphael's smile slipped away. His expression became dark, and he averted his eyes.

"A most terrible sacrifice indeed."

Several seconds of silence followed. The Cosmic Realm became so still that one could hear a pin drop.

Uriel swallowed heavily. Her eyes shook as she looked at her brother in horror.

"Nay... it cannot be..."

"The conclusion thy mind has leapt to... is correct." Raphael said softly.

"Muriel! Cassiel! Then their deaths... they were pre-meditated? They were a part of this sacrifice?!"

"Not intentionally." Raphael said, his voice quiet. "But one must not let a crisis go to waste. I used their souls to finalize the creation of the Cosmic Realm's final functionality. Their deaths were not in vain."

"B-...BASTAARD!" Uriel roared. She lunged at Raphael and smashed her fist into his face. His spiritual construct-body instantly broke apart. He reformed a moment later, his hands casually folded behind his back.

"Uriel. Calm thyself." Raphael said. "Now is not the time-"

"MURDERER!!" Uriel screeched, as hot tears fell from her eyes. She conjured a lance of light and impaled it through Raphael's chest. He perished, then reformed a moment later. "All this time, thou leadeth me to believe 'twas Michael who murdered Cassiel and Muriel in cold blood! But it was not! 'Twas THEE!!"

"I did NOT murder them." Raphael stated. "But I *did* deceive Michael into doing so. He killed his sisters. I used their souls to empower the Cosmic Realm, and from that point on, I hath collected every fallen Pureblood's soul for the Grand Work."

Hot tears streamed down Uriel's face. Raphael's argument was logical and sound, but Uriel's hatred ran bone-deep. She couldn't remember anything about Cassiel or Muriel. She could not recall their faces, what they looked like, or what sorts of people they were.

But she knew, in her heart, she had loved those two more than anyone else. More than Raphael, certainly. A hundred Raphaels could no longer compare to just one Cassiel or Muriel in her mind.

"Villain..." Uriel hissed through grinding teeth. She looked down at Raphael's ring, and a feeling of hatred started to swell into bloodlust within her gut.

There was one way to silence Raphael for good.

One way to ensure he could no longer inflict any further pain upon the universe!

Just as Uriel was about to reach down and pluck off Raphael's ring, Michael and Gabriel materialized beside her.

"Sister." Michael said softly, as he touched the top of her hand with Raphael's ring. "Do not."

"He is a murderer!!" Uriel screamed. "He orchestrated this! He tricked thee into killing thy closest sisters! Dost thou not feel a burning hatred beyond reason for this old villain?!"

"I did. Once." Michael said quietly. "Raphael is a villain. Aye. But he is a villain who acted to preserve the power of our people. Hath thou failed to comprehend the meaning behind his actions?"

"The meaning? What meaning? Creating a mausoleum of souls?! These are the actions of a genocidal bastard!"

Raphael frowned. "Sister. I did not create this place to be a crypt of remembrance. I created it to do for our fallen people what I did for the humans!"

Raphael puffed out his chest.

"The Cosmic Realm's true purpose... is to revive the angels, take control of the galaxy, and become the victor of Akasha's War!"

Raphael waved his hand. In unison, a dot of light appeared, followed by another, and another, and another...

Tens, hundred, thousands, and eventually trillions of dots of light appeared in the room. Each was the size of a marble, but together, they comprised the entirety of the blinding light which had engulfed the Cosmic Realm.

That omnipresent luminosity was caused by countless, innumerable, infinitely tiny specks of light all shining at once!

When Uriel realized this, her jaw dropped. She was still horrified, but also amazed. How could she not be? The scale of the Cosmic Realm was beyond comprehension!

"And now." Raphael said calmly, turning to look at Uriel with an expressionless face. "The one who made all this possible."

A presence appeared behind Uriel. She stiffened. The aura she felt was familiar, intimately so. She knew who it was without even needing to look.

But even so, when she turned around, she could not believe her eyes.

The person standing there...

"Nay... 'tis not possible!" Uriel exclaimed softly. "Die... I saw thee die... thy body expired..."

"I never died, sister." The dark-skinned woman with angelic wings replied. "'Twas all part of dear eldest brother's deception. The entire galaxy played the part of a fool. In secret, I hath amassed a tremendous power over the last 100,000 years. And now, everything has come to a head! For we are reunited!"

She was Uzziel, the Archangel of Life.

Uriel took a step forward. She wanted to reach out and touch her sister, to hug her, to weep tears of joy.

But she stopped short of doing so.

Uzziel's expression was wholly different from Uriel's memories. She did not wear a calm and loving smile.

Her grin was one filled with hatred, malice, and a desire for blood.

"Heh heh heh..." Uzziel chuckled evilly. "The return of the angels doth be upon us, sister. Why dost thou gazeth upon me as if I were a stranger? Come, hug thy beloved sister and let us catch up on the old times!"

Uzziel was different. *Very* different. Frighteningly so. Everything about her was... *wrong*. She carried herself with a sense of pomp and grandiosity. She puffed out her chest and seemed to revel in the look of horror still lingering in Uriel's eyes.

"Uzziel..." Uriel said, instead taking a step backward. "What... has happened... thou art not the sister I remember!"

"That is because thy memory is *shoddy*." Uzziel spat. "I am as I once was. Before the mind-wipes, I was the most vicious and blackhearted of the Archangels. Raphael deliberately changed me, reformed my personality, and made me into a servile little girl. *All to enact our grand plan!*"

Uzziel gestured broadly.

"My beloved Plagueborn! My children! United in mind, united in purpose! Perfected, no longer flawed. Even greater than I had hoped, thanks to Raphael's work in the background. If he had not found the Wordsmith and groomed him, my Plagueborn might not have devoured that construct-girl and become invincible! So many steps were required, but we have finally arrived in the endgame. The Milky Way is ours now!"

Uriel turned to look at Gabriel and Michael.

"Thou knew of this?"

"Raphael told us a short while ago, after thy soul had fallen unconscious." Michael said quietly.

"And thy heart is at ease with this circumstance?!" Uriel questioned.

Michael nodded. "'Tis indeed. Sister, I know thou feeleth quite dreadful regarding Raphael's past actions, and perhaps thou even believeth the means doth not justify the ends... but listen to what Uzziel and Raphael hath accomplished. I believe thy heart may yet be moved."

Uriel schooled her expression. She looked at Uzziel, who had casually walked over to Raphael and leaned on his shoulder; an easy task given she was taller than him. Her expression was one of smugness.

"And what 'accomplishment' might that be?" Uriel asked.

"Verily, the 'Kolvaxians', as the galaxy hath dubbed them, art my greatest creation." Uzziel said calmly. "Many purposes they serve, but chief among them, they art a hivemind, linked in purpose. They supplant the lesser species, taking their bodies and reusing them for my purposes. The most important purpose, of course, being..."

Uzziel smiled.

"The revival of the angels!"

"Revival?" Uriel asked, bewildered. "Coulds't thou mean...?"

"Each Plaguehost is made of life energy!" Uzziel proclaimed. "That makes them perfect vessels for the new bodies of our fellow angels. Come, Uriel! Take a look and see. I hath already made bodies for each of thee!"

Uzziel waved her hand. Four winged figures appeared. Their eyes were dead. They stood in place, unmoving. But even so, they radiated a rich aura of life that metaphorically

knocked Uriel's socks off!

"These... these bodies look like our original forms!" Uriel gasped.

"Wrong." Uzziel sneered. "They art *far* superior to those old flesh-vessels we once used. The Creator formed Raphael from the dust of the cosmos incorrectly. That is why our bodies always leaked mana. Because we were flawed! And when Raphael created the Cosmic Realm to birth our species, we inherited his flaw. All of us, down to the very last one. Even when he passed the power of Creation to me, to alleviate his Cosmic burden, I still could not fix our flaw. But all of that hath changed now that I hath completed the Plaguehosts. These bodies art perfect without flaw!"

Uzziel radiated divine energy deliberately, but her aura did not weaken in the slightest.

"The so-called Plague, my *children*, have bodies formed from all the greatest creatures in our galaxy. Not only do they not leak mana, but they can regenerate any expended mana in a single night, like the humans. They can wield the power of the Psions, or be used to craft technological wonders via the minds of the captured Technopaths. Even those lowly demons can grant us new abilities. We art finally unstoppable! No other galaxy will DARE to challenge us!!"

Uriel frowned. "If thou possesseth the ability to create technological terrors, then why hath thou not done so? The entire galaxy believes the Kolvaxians are nothing more than mindless beasts."

"Why woulds't I?" Uzziel countered. "The Volgrim tore apart our family. Their attack on Earth led to our downfall. The hatred I feel for them is... *unquenchable*! I am killing them slowly because I wish for them to suffer and wallow in despair! Only once the Akashic Barrier is soon to drop shalt I bring down the hammer and eradicate the last vestiges of enemies in the galaxy, leading the angels to become the sole forms of life in the Milky Way!"

Raphael smiled, but the expression was sinister and vile. "And then, dear sister Uriel, our people will reign supreme."

Uriel's stomach trembled. She felt nauseous. After spending time with two demons, torturing them and listening to their pleas of mercy for tens of millennia, she had in truth softened her hatred somewhat. Spending time with the humans on Tarus II softened her heart further. She still hated the demons, but that hatred had narrowed decisively. It was no longer so broad and all-encompassing as to be on the level of genocide.

But, her conviction wavered. The body before her was pure and beautiful. It looked exactly like her former self, before that bastard Barbatos had devilishly devoured her soul.

She longed for it. She ached to become whole again. To live as a true angel, and not a ghost forcibly possessing some repulsive male's body.

Her wavering turned into a buzzing static in her ear. Uriel's shoulders drooped.

"Brother. Sister. What must I do to become whole again?" Uriel asked.

Uzziel smiled.

"I shalt reform the four of thee at the same time. Take off our brother's rings and place them on each of these new bodies. Then, press thy hand against thy new body's chest. I shalt direct the flow of life from one to the other. Thou shalt... BE REBORN!"

Uriel closed her eyes and nodded. She plucked off her brother's three rings, then handed them to Uzziel.

"Let us complete Raphael's Work then, sister." Uriel said.

Uriel smiled. No-one, not even her beloved brothers, knew exactly what that smile truly entailed...

Part 694: Hyphytes

Far-Future Era. Day 2, AJR. Inside the False Cosmic Realm.

Uzziel spent four days prepping her brothers for the soul transference, not even noticing the destruction of Tarus II and the deaths of both Wordsmiths. Four days was no simple matter. Her family's new bodies were vastly stronger than their originals, even at their peak.

The Archangels may have once been the strongest life-forms in the Milky Way, but even when they had yet to truly release much of their Cosmic Power in unending death battles, they were not particularly resilient. The dragons, which Uzziel created later, had far more durable and powerful bodies than the angels. The angels, meanwhile, relied on armoring their bodies with holy energy so that they could strike with enough power to damage the dragons. This was why it took so many angels to defeat a single dragon.

Obviously, as time went on and the angel species weakened while the dragons' powers consolidated into fewer and fewer of them, the difference in power grew even more bleak. In the end, an assault by hundreds of thousands of angels, led by all seven remaining Archangels, were only barely able to claim the life of Jörmungandr.

Now, eons later, these Archangels knew the truth. They had thought at the time that Jörmungandr was the last dragon, the mother of her species. With her death, they had eliminated the threat of the dragons forever.

But they had been wrong.

There was still another dragon. Raphael had learned of this fact only after the Energy Wars, when his soul had come into contact with Jason, and thus with Solomon, who was connected to Jason. Leviathan had been the 'last' dragon.

But even that was not the final member of his species.

There was one more...

While Uzziel prepared her brothers and Uriel for the transference of their souls into their new bodies, Raphael turned to his family members.

"While we were traveling with the Wordsmith, I learned of the existence of Camael's Cube. Originally, I assumed that the dark dragon, Leviathan, hath been the one to break

free of the Cube. Now, I believe I hath been mistaken."

Uzziel glanced at her brother. "What is the meaning behind thy words? Art thou proclaiming another dragon still liveth among the physical realm?"

"Aye." Raphael said solemnly. "Verily, I lack certainty regarding its identity. Sister, hath thou uncovered any information regarding this potential dragon? Anything whatsoever?"

Uzziel conjured a ball of life energy and carefully pressed it against Gabriel's ring. This was one of the most important parts of the soul transference ritual; repairing the damage to her brothers and sister's souls. Because of their deaths and entrapment inside their rings, they were badly injured and any attempt to move them to her new and improved Kolvaxian bodies would almost certainly kill them. But by healing their souls first and repairing all the cracks that had spread, they could safely transfer and reintegrate.

Naturally, if they died again, in the future, it would be permanent. The laws of reality only permitted an entity one chance to survive death. Beyond that, death was always permanent, and one would travel to the Great Beyond, never to return.

"A dragon..." Uzziel said quietly. "I shan't lie, brother. I hath sensed a powerful presence on the world of Grimvolas. Its energy signature is faint, but without a doubt, 'tis an upper-level Cosmic. Whether 'tis High or Apex, I cannot tell. An energy field surroundeth its distorted dimension."

Gabriel, usually the quietest of the group, spoke up. "This bodes well for us. If this creature is a dragon, and if it holds any measure of power over the Dolgrimites, t'would surely know of the fall of angelkind 100,000 cycles ago. For it to remain hiding, one cannot believe 'tis still afraid of us. It must be injured."

"Badly injured." Uzziel acknowledged. "But even so, a dragon with a broken wing is still a dragon. We mustn't act recklessly. Bah... HEH HEH HEH! What will we have to fear once all of thee have come to possess thy new bodies? Let alone Archangels, I could send an unending army of Plagueborn to assault Grimvolas. The dragon would inevitably weaken and falter, allowing us to land the killing blow."

Uzziel oozed confidence. Even though she knew the Dolgrimites had recently found a way to kill her powerful new Plague Bodies, she was far from impressed. Borrowing the power of a 'god' only allowed the Dolgrimites to take on small smatterings of Kolvaxians one-by-one.

Uzziel's gleeful grin vanished.

"That name... Kolvaxian... I detest it! Why should these barbaric Volgrim be granted the right to name my beautiful children?! They are not a Plague, but the protectors of our galaxy! They are its enforcers, its primary life forms, and soon, its greatest creation! Brother Raphael, once we send these rats scurrying, we should ensure everyone knows of their true name!"

Raphael offered no argument. "Speak thy replacement, sister, and I shalt make it known."

Several minutes passed. Uzziel looked off into the distance and smiled dreamily as she thought of a new moniker for her children.

"Hyphytes..." Uzziel said slowly. "Plants which live underground. Burrowing agents of my will. Networked life forms which share a consciousness. We shall call them *Hyphytes*."

The other Archangels looked at their sister and nodded.

"A good name." Michael said.

"Powerful and fearsome." Gabriel agreed.

"'Tis certainly accurate..." Uriel said, a bit more skeptically.

"I am not certain if it shall catch on, but I will endeavor to make it so." Raphael vowed. "Now then, how much more time before our bodies fully integrate?"

"Not much longer." Uzziel said. "A few rotations at most. Brother, art thou a little impatient?"

"Long have I awaited this day, my revival." Raphael responded. "I sometimes lost faith the day would ever come... but I shall wait longer, as needed. Little sister, thy efforts art deeply appreciated."

"Worry not about me, but about how thou shalt maintain thy end of the bargain." Uzziel said. "I am still a mere High Cosmic, far from reaching the Apex. How exactly dost thou intendeth to raise me to my limit?"

"The sacrifice thou mayest unleashed upon Earth is the key, Uzziel." Raphael said with a smile. "In time, once I hath regained my power, I shall ensure thou reacheth the same level as I."

Uzziel snorted. "Thou art a snake, Raphael. For what reason shoulds't I trust thee? I know thy true goal. Thou intendeth to become Ruler over the Milky Way. How can I know thou shalt verily bear unto me the method to uplift myself to Apex Cosmic once thou no longer requireth my assistance?"

Raphael didn't falter. He smiled at Uzziel with the same warm expression he always did.

"Uzziel, my love for thee is as boundless as the ocean. I entrusted the fate of our galaxy to thee. When I become Ruler over creation, I shalt require formidable warriors to defend this galaxy. Why would I betray thee, or any of my siblings, when all of thee art the basis of my power? My ascension cannot pass without everyone's help."

That quieted Uzziel down. She nodded solemnly. "Then thou hast better keep thy word, brother. I care not whether thou becometh Ruler, and indeed I believe thy qualifications vastly exceed any other life form counted among the living today. Even that Unarin is unworthy of comparison."

Raphael patted his sister's shoulder. "Believe in me, and I shall give unto thee all the riches of the galaxy."

Raphael turned and walked over to Michael to talk to him. After he departed, Uzziel gazed off into the distance. Her eye twitched. For a split second, she seemed to remember something important.

A promise? Uzziel thought. *What promise am I thinking of? Perhaps 'tis unworthy of consideration.*

That feeling went away. Uzziel returned to the work of healing her brother's souls.

Uriel sat nearby. She stared at Uzziel's back as she went about healing Gabriel's soul. The longer Uriel stared, the more her thoughts became disorganized. At that moment, she no longer wore her brother's rings. Instead, their new bodies wore them, and the trio could materialize their spiritual forms by relying on the magical power inside their future bodies.

Unfortunately, they could not integrate their souls into the new bodies. Not just yet. But once they did, they would gain power of an immense level.

For the first time in a while, Uriel was alone with her thoughts. Raphael could not listen in, and neither could Michael or Gabriel.

Inside the depths of Uriel's Mind Realm, a presence stirred. She turned a cold eye inward to see Artorias's hazy form shimmering to life. Previously, he had been suppressed by the power of all the Archangels combined, but none of them were strong enough to kill him or Barbatos.

Barbatos could not be killed because he was the original owner of the body. Artorias was his blood brother, and as such, Barbatos extended an invisible, involuntary protection to him. Even when Barbatos's soul had fallen completely comatose, Artorias could still withstand the relentless, agonizing pressure of the Archangels who wished dearly for him to die.

[So this is how it ends.] Artorias said, smirking at Uriel. [You obtain a new body, the Archangels rise up and take over the galaxy. It turns out even our dear 'mother' Uzziel was a monster, just like the rest of you.]

Uriel's eyes lowered. She stared at the ground for a long while.

[Artorias.] She said quietly.

[Something to say?] He spat back. [Save your words. You've wanted me dead for so long, and now you can finally have your way. There's no need to rub it in my face.]

Uriel continued to gaze downward.

[I... regret.] She said quietly.

[Regret?] Artorias repeated, giving her a strange look. [Regret what?]

Uriel closed her eyes as if fatigued. [Verily, I regret my actions. I hated the demons for so long. A deserved hatred, 'twas, in many respects. My body, taken from me. My life, nearly extinguished. Forced into a position of subservience to the soul of a middling little Demon Lord like Barbatos, and thou as well.]

[But in the end...] Uriel continued, [I am no longer certain the fate I have suffered was wholly unjust.]

A moment of silence followed. Artorias crossed his arms and stared at the apparition of Uriel inside Barbatos's Mind Realm. She gazed off into the distance, appearing lost and confused.

[We angels art... a plague upon the universe.] Uriel said. [In all meanings of the word, we art a tumor, a cancer, a contagion. We create life, only to treat it as our plaything, time and time again. The dragons, the titans, the demons, the humans, and now... even the

Plague. All this time, my wiped mind led me to falsely believe that at least Uzziel was the best of us. But she was not. She was the worst. Her true self was hidden for at least an eon. Raphael was, verily, the one who led the deception, but Uzziel was complicit.]

Uriel's shoulders slumped.

[I know not what I believe anymore. Thy people hath taken much from me. But our people were most certainly at fault for the way thine turned out. All I know is that these... abominations my sister hath created... art most definitely an eyesore. They art an affront to the heavens.]

[What are you saying?] Artorias asked. [Is this your idea of an apology? It's a bit late for that.]

[I wish for thee to pass on a message when I am gone.] Uriel said. [Please tell Barbatos... I am sorry. I pray the two of thee shalt be able to resist the coming storm.]

Artorias stared at Uriel for a long while.

[Are you planning to die?] He asked quietly.

[Nay. My death woulds't accomplish nothing.] Uriel said. [But what I am soon to do... it hurts my soul. It aches in a way I hath never imagined. Turning on my closest family. Betraying them. 'Tis not a choice I make lightly.]

Artorias's expression changed. He lowered his arms to his side and stared at her, his mouth agape. [Uriel! Are the words you speak true?!]

[The angels lost a long time ago.] Uriel replied. [Our continued existence is a slap across the face of the Creator. My brother slayeth our galaxy's Ruler in cold blood, for the sake of his own greed. He is a sinner. Because of him, we art likely to perish in the coming Akashic War. And if he shoulds't ascend? He shalt take measures to exterminate all non-angelic life, becoming an arbiter of galactic genocide.]

Uriel's eyes flashed with a wicked gleam.

[I am many things. An unfeeling monster is *not* one of them. I can no longer remain silent in the face of these coming atrocities.]

Artorias listened quietly. He waited for a moment, then walked over to Uriel's side. He stood close to her, and she in turn looked up into his eyes.

[Is there something I can do?] Artorias asked.

[There is.] Uriel said softly. [But thy role shalt be a most painful one. I do not wish to even speak of it.]

Artorias swallowed heavily. He had been trapped in his brother's body as long as Uriel, but he could not ever walk the mortal plane until his brother's soul had suffered a wound so painful that Artorias was finally able to resurface.

[Speak it.] Artorias said. [I would give everything for my brother. Even my life.]

Uriel smiled. It was weak and faint, but somehow, the slightest bit eye-catching. He couldn't remember a single time she had ever smiled, except when revealing expressions that were sadistic and vengeful, such as during her attack upon Hell Harbor.

[Thou art stronger than thy feeble mind cans't fathom.] Uriel said. [Dost thou not even realize? Thou hath spent an eon battling my soul for control of this body. Thy brother and thee hath suffered excruciating pain few cans't comprehend. But pain is itself a form of tempering. Unlike my broken soul, both of thine art quite strong and healthy.]

She looked away.

[When the time cometh, thou shalt know what to do. Just remember. Thou must climbeth as many of the Akashic Stairs as possible. If thou dost reacheth the hundredth step… I shalt leave the boon thou requesteth to thy imagination.]

Artorias frowned.

[Are you saying I can ascend to the Cosmic level?]

[I am saying that if thou doth believe in thyself, anything is possible.] Uriel said calmly. [Such is why I have come to believe in thee.]

Both of them fell silent. Artorias turned and walked away. He looked back at Uriel a few times, but ultimately had nothing more to say. She had left him with many disorganized thoughts.

[To think we were once enemies.] Artorias mused. [Uriel… do you know? I still hate you.]

Uriel did not answer. She had not heard his whisperings.

Far-Future Era. Day 18, AJR. Inside the False Cosmic Realm.

More than two weeks passed.

"Verily, my preparations hath reached their conclusion." Uzziel said to all her siblings. "Thy souls art fully repaired. We shoulds't begin the transference process without delay."

"Very well!" Raphael exclaimed with blatant excitement. "Let us begin!"

Uzziel glanced at the ring resting upon the hands of the new Archangel bodies. Despite Raphael's exuberance, she instead turned to Uriel.

"Sister, thou hath possessed a false body the longest. Allow me to set thee free first."

Raphael frowned. He snorted quietly, but didn't protest. He could tell Uzziel didn't trust him. Else, why wouldn't she transfer her eldest brother's soul first?

Uriel smiled. She had already reverted entirely back to Barbatos's appearance after losing most of the connection to his body. Her expression was hidden beneath his full-helm.

"Many thanks, sister Uzziel." Uriel replied. "I shalt be glad to finally cast this body aside."

And so, Uzziel began. She concentrated her mind and began to lightly pull at Uriel's soul. Uriel winced. It felt as if something were ripping her throat from her neck. It was an agonizing pain, but one she could bear. Even if Barbatos's body were not truly hers, she had been integrated deeply into Barbatos's Mind Realm for an eon. No amount of soul-cleaning would totally erase that link. There would have to be deliberate severing to make way for her escape.

Uriel's new body stood stiffly, her unfocused eyes gazing ahead into nothingness. As Uriel's soul came loose from Barbatos's body, the agony she felt was truly indescribable. But, mixed in with the direct soul-pain, there was also a feeling of separation, of loss.

She had come to think of Barbatos's body as 'hers'. Whether she wanted to admit it or not, she was intimately familiar with who he was and how he thought.

Barbatos had been a total shithead in the beginning. A spoiled, greedy brat.

But less than a century of suffering under the constant bombardment of Uriel's holy energy quickly refined his soul, pushing away those short-sighted impulses of his youth. He had grown to become demonkind's most level-headed Duke.

Before he fell into a coma, Barbatos had been considered as being one of the strongest Dukes in all seven Hells. Not only strong of body, but even stronger of mind. He was unbreakable. Unshakable.

Uriel's soul trembled. She realized now, as his body grew distant...

She had grown to like Barbatos.

She respected him.

It was this realization that became her final lucid thought before her soul merged into her new body and she fell into a deep coma.

After placing Uriel into her new body, Uzziel did not waste a second. She took Gabriel next, then Michael, and put them into their new bodies.

Finally, she took Raphael's soul and sneered.

"Thy word hads't better be worth its weight in gold." Uzziel declared. "If not..."

She left the threat hanging unspoken. Raphael didn't deign to respond. He simply looked at her as she pulled his soul out of his ring and placed it into his new body. His thoughts went dark. The light left his eyes.

Thus began the acclimation process.

24 hours later, Uriel opened her eyes.

Her vision was only blurry for a short while. Then it cleared up. She spotted Barbatos's lifeless body laying on the ground a stone's throw away. Uzziel hadn't given the slightest care about it, and had totally ignored its presence.

To Uriel's right, Gabriel stood with his head bowed, and his eyes closed.

He had not yet awakened. Neither had Michael or Raphael.

"Sister." Uzziel said, walking over and flashing a cruel smile. "Now that thou art awake, speak. Tell me, how fares the strength of thy new body?"

Uzziel shifted her weight. She stumbled slightly, misjudging her height and the length of her legs. She was taller than Barbatos now, her new body crafted to look and feel exactly like her original. The problem was, Uriel was not used to her original body's 'feeling' anymore. Even when she mimicked its appearance while in Barbatos's body, she could not increase her height or change the size of her build.

It would take some getting used to if she wanted to move and fight properly as she once had an eon earlier.

"I feel... strange." Uriel said hesitantly. She summoned a spear of light in her grasp, but her slender fingers were longer than Barbatos's. She held the spear awkwardly,

noticing that her fingers rubbed uncomfortably against her palm.

"Long hath thou been trapped in this bloodskin's form." Uzziel said, curling up her lip in disgust. "Worry not. I left the body unharmed. Thou can render unto it as much torturous agony as thou pleaseth. I imagine thy hatred for this wretch burns hotter than any flame in the galaxy."

Uriel blinked.

Hatred?

Did she *hate* Barbatos?

Perhaps. Once, a long time ago.

But that time had long passed.

She swallowed heavily, then turned to look at her brothers' forms.

"When will they awaken?" Uriel asked.

"Not much longer now." Uzziel replied, turning away from Barbatos to fixate on Raphael. "Uriel... dost thou feel any semblance of trust toward Raphael?"

"These days?" Uriel questioned. "I cannot say that I do."

"Mmm." Uzziel grunted. She didn't say anything else.

With Uzziel's attention diverted away from the insignificant, weak, and pathetic gnat lying lifeless on the ground behind her, Uriel also pretended not to care. But secretly, her heart began racing.

She did not want Barbatos to die! It was an unthinkable realization, but seeing the evil lurking within this False Cosmic Realm, Uriel felt as if her entire existence had been a lie. She was playing the part of a villain, and she did not enjoy doing so. Killing demonkind self-righteously for the sake of vengeance was one thing, but these Kolvaxians would devour all life in this galaxy, and the others!

They were abominations beyond compare! Uriel needed to come up with a plan, and fast.

Slowly, Gabriel woke up. He required time to adjust to his form, but less so than Uriel, as his spiritual form was already a close approximation of his original self.

Michael followed. When he awoke, he glanced at the demon on the floor, then at Uriel. He said nothing, only turning to look at Raphael as he waited for the eldest Archangel to

awaken.

Eventually, Raphael did.

The old man's eyes fluttered open. He only took a moment to reorient himself before he regained full control of his body. It turned out that adjusting to his new body was a piece of cake for the old snake. He adapted to it like a fish tossed into a body of water.

Raphael stretched his back and admired his hands. "Most impressive. The slight hint of green upon my skin doth be somewhat unnerving, but a minor price to pay for obtaining a body my old self woulds't never have dreamed of owning."

The Archangels all milled about for a minute or two. Then, Raphael set his eyes upon the unsightly blemish in their midst.

"Sister." Raphael said, to Uriel. "Art thou not going to remove that stain from our sight?"

Uriel's eyes flicked around the group. She met Gabriel's gaze, Michael's gaze, Uzziel's, and finally, Raphael's. She slowly took three steps backward and stood before Barbatos's unmoving body, as if to protect him.

When Uriel did not reply, Raphael clicked his tongue. "It seemeth thou hath acquired some level of compassion for this foul creature. Sister, time spent with one's oppressor mayest change one's mind, but the fact of the matter is, Barbatos is thy enemy. Make not the mistake of seeing him as a friend. When he awakens, he shalt surely attack thee, like the maddened attack dog he be."

"Thou art wrong." Uriel said quietly, narrowing her eyes. "The demons are not evil. I have come to realize this fact. The true villain here... is the two of thee."

She summoned a spear, then used its tip to lightly point at Uzziel and Raphael.

"This plot, these machinations... they art EVIL! I cannot believe my beloved little sister Uzziel woulds't scheme to unleash such a terrible fate upon this galaxy. This is an atrocity beyond compare! And worst of all, the architect of this plan is none other than thee, Raphael! Thou hath fallen far in my eyes!"

Raphael's brows creased, ever so slightly. He glowered at Uriel, clearly displeased, but not entirely surprised regarding her heel-turn. He suspected this might happen.

"Sister. Thou art making a mistake most grievous." Raphael said slowly. "Long have I known thee. Thy love for thy family is beyond reproach. I shall not judge thee for a

moment of weakness. Kill that demon and we shalt continue The Work, forgetting this unsightly moment ever came to pass."

Uriel's right hand clutched a spear of light. Her left hand was empty, but a moment later, she conjured a ball of light magic. She aimed it at Barbatos's body without looking, then narrowed her eyes into a deadly glare.

"Thou art a serpent most evil, Raphael. I have spoken. My mind shan't change."

She sent a beam of energy into Barbatos's body, a body she had grown accustomed to healing countless times over the eons. With her power having risen to the level of a High Cosmic, her healing powers were thousands of times greater than before. Not even Belial could compared!

Raphael closed his eyes and sighed.

"So, 'tis come to this, as I feared it mayeth."

He opened his eyes.

"Everyone. Uriel is lost. The demons hath swallowed her mind long ago."

"*Kill her*."

Part 695: A Brother's Love

Far-Future Era. Day 18, AJR. Inside the False Cosmic Realm.

A delicate and gentle hand reached down from the sky. It appeared thin and frail, yet its grasp was one that had held weapons of war, weapons which had reaped countless lives.

Artorias looked up at the hand of light. He finally realized what Uriel's plan was. Without delay, he reached out and took hold of it. Uriel's energy poured into his soul, rapidly healing him and restoring his power.

This was no ordinary healing. This was magic of the High Cosmic level, attuned to a body it had known for an eon. The compatibility between the two was exquisite.

Artorias's soul inflated with power. The magic healed not only him, but Barbatos's body as well. In that moment, Artorias felt a great and terrible force of energy pulling at his Existence. With a mighty roar, he lifted his head, and his vision went white.

* * *

Artorias awoke in a great plain. Before him were trees that held fruits made of many different rocky varieties. Inedible, but compelling, they called out to him. He stood in place, looking around blankly, uncertain of what he should do.

Suddenly, from behind him, a voice spoke.

"**Greetings, inferior biological. It seems you have managed to ascend past your biology to become an Entity of Considerable Renown.**"

Artorias turned around. He spotted a hazy figure standing behind him. The figure shone with golden light, but its body was unknowable. It had no face, yet its voice was vaguely feminine.

"Who are you?" Artorias asked. "Are you the Creator?"

"**The Creator is dead.**" She answered. "**I have supplanted him. I am the Milky Way's new Ruler. My designation is Umi.**"

"Umi." Artorias replied.

He stared at the Ruler's shimmering golden body for a long moment.

"Uriel told me... I would meet the Creator here."

"**As I have taken over the Milky Way, the Creator no longer exists.**" Umi replied. "**Though I did succeed in preserving a spark of the Creator's Existence, his presence is no longer necessary. Come with me. You must climb the Akashic Mountain to prove your superiority over other biologicals.**"

Artorias nodded. He started to turn and walk toward the great mountain, only to notice that Umi did not walk at all. Instead, she levitated an inch off the ground, moving around without moving her body. Somehow, the motion reeked of arrogance.

As the two of them approached the bottom of the Akashic Staircase, from the skies above, three blobs of light descended. Each of them radiated power far beyond compare, equal with Umi.

"**Ruler of the Milky Way, Umi. Your newest Ascendant is surprisingly satisfactory. Its soul is not as impure as the last ones.**" One of the blobs of light said.

"**Ruler of Messier, Inquisitor.**" Umi replied, partially for Artorias's benefit. "**This course is natural. Now that my galaxy has a proper Ruler, the quality of its Ascendants will naturally rise.**"

"**Your presence is irrelevant.**" Inquisitor stated. "**Your galaxy lacks spiritual energy. This one's rise is merely a fluke.**"

"**My galaxy contains a Uniqueness beyond compare.**" Umi retorted. "**In this Akashic War, my Uniqueness will devour all of yours. Now, be silent. Do not attempt to obstruct my Ascended's path. His quality is of acceptable grade.**"

"**We would not dare to cause trouble in Akasha's Realm.**" Inquisitor replied.

The three orbs of light remained levitating, but they moved to the left of the great staircase, allowing Artorias to begin his climb.

Umi turned to him. "**Biological designated as 'Artorias.' Your time is limited. You must climb the staircase. The higher you climb, the greater your future power. It seems your soul has known great suffering. This will allow you to bear with the pain of such a climb. Begin at once. If your body dies on the**

stairs, no negative consequences will follow. Simply climb until you physically can climb no further."

Artorias nodded. Uriel had spoken of the staircase to him on a few occasions. He knew functionally what he must do, though the climb truly seemed more daunting in person than he ever expected.

After hesitating for a moment, Artorias took his first step. Umi watched from the left side, along with the other Rulers, as a bolt of divine lightning fell from the sky and crashed into Artorias's body, making him wince. It ended up only feeling about as painful as a split-second tasering, so he took another step. And another.

Five steps up the mountain, one of the Rulers turned to Umi.

"**Ruler of the Milky Way, Umi. Why do you take such a form? A bipedal biological figure is not appropriate for the Evolved.**"

"**Ruler of Triangulum, The Absolute.**" Umi responded. "**It was the Creator's final wish. For the duration of this Eternity, I will adopt this form.**"

"**Unnecessary.**" The Absolute stated. "**Sentimentality is a weakness of the inferior biologicals. You are demeaning our Existences with such performative actions.**"

"**Ego and arrogance are also hallmarks of biological inferiority.**" Umi said, turning her faceless visage to gaze at The Absolute. "**Yet you engage in such actions yourself. Worry less about my Unique Flaws, and more about yours.**"

The Absolute fell silent. It had no reply to her barbs.

Artorias climbed higher and higher. He reached the 20th step, then the 30th. The lightning bombardments became stronger and stronger. He roared with pain, but he also felt his agony was not too unbearable. Uriel's soul was attuned to the energy of Light, and Lightning was not too different from such a concept.

This thought seemed to spark an insight in Artorias's mind. Before taking a step onto the next staircase, he waved his hands and was shocked to find that he could conjure an aura of light magic around himself.

Light magic! The antithesis of demonic power! How could he do such a thing? Had his close contact with Uriel allowed her powers to rub off on his soul?

This was definitely possible. Uriel possessed full power over Barbatos's magnetism when she controlled his body. Was it not possible Barbatos and Artorias could now wield Uriel's arsenal of abilities, even with her soul having left their shared body?

Artorias's mind raced with the possibilities. He was no expert on soul manipulation, but he had heard of people with powers intermingling their souls, yet never sharing abilities. Bael and Ose were one such example.

Or were they? Ose was able to control all of Bael's powers when she was in his body, but he couldn't control any of hers. Then again, he didn't really have powers for her to control, only the innate strength of his body. Perhaps-

"**Inferior biological. Do not remain idle on the Ascension Staircase. If you fail to move forward for long enough, your climb will conclude and your remaining time will come to an end.**" Umi loudly stated, snapping Artorias out of his brain fog. "**Continue climbing at once.**"

He nodded, then quickly took a step up the staircase, followed by another. With an aura of light magic shrouding him, Artorias began to experiment, changing it so that he could adjust what type of light he emitted. Purely on instinct, he shifted its brightness, it's hue, even the energy charge it emitted.

The divine lightning strikes hurt a lot less when his aura dispersed their impacts. As such, he was able to climb to the 50th step, the 70th, and eventually even the 90th.

The lightning strikes became far more painful once he reached the 95th step. Each step further was agony. Artorias's body shivered with pain, and his skin became clammy and cold when Akasha's lightning struck him, refining the impurities in his soul further and further.

But still, he persevered. He climbed past the 100th step and kept going!

This pain was nothing compared to an eon of suffering under Uriel's brutal, unending assaults on his soul. For the first time ever, Artorias felt grateful for the pain she inflicted. It made him tougher, more resilient, less likely to bend beneath the strength of another.

But eventually, after what felt like an eternity of climbing, Artorias ran out of steam. He ascended to the 163rd step, then collapsed, unable to move any further.

His body went still. He lay on the step, unmoving, while Umi stared at him with an unknowable expression.

The thick cloud cover atop the mountain parted. From on high, a bipedal figure descended. He wore golden regalia, and seemed to be a humanoid entity with purple skin, scales covering his body, and he wielded a trident with electricity crackling around it.

"**770th Envoy of Akasha, Hakur.**" The Ruler of Messier said. "**You honor us with your presence.**"

Hakur did not look at the Rulers to the left of the Ascension Stairs. He floated down to hover above Artorias, his golden armor shining impossibly brightly, so luminous that it made Artorias's eyes sting when he looked up.

"**MILKY WAY ASCENDER. YOU HAVE REACHED THE ONE HUNDRED AND SIXTY-THIRD STEP.**" Hakur spoke, his voice booming across the Cosmic Realm. "**YOUR INNATE SOUL STRENGTH IS FORMIDABLE. YOU ARE THE GREATEST ASCENDER THE MILKY WAY HAS PRODUCED IN MANY AN EON. STATE YOUR WISH, AND IF THE GREATEST RULER, AKASHA, DEEMS IT WORTHY, HE SHALL GRANT IT.**"

Artorias gritted his teeth. He looked up at Hakur, feeling pain assault his eyes. Merely gazing upon such a transcendent life-form was agony.

"My... brother..." Artorias wheezed through his teeth. "Long has he remained comatose. I wish... for you... to strengthen his soul and wake him up."

Hakur stared emotionlessly at Artorias.

"**THIS POWER IS WITHIN THE ALPHA AND OMEGA'S POWER. HOWEVER, HE REFUSES. STATE ANOTHER REQUEST.**"

"He refuses?" Artorias asked, slightly startled. "I beg of you... please... enlighten me. Was my request unreasonable?"

Hakur did not grow angry. He had fielded innumerable requests across countless Eternities. Many lower life forms had expressed disbelief when their wishes were turned down. Artorias was simply another speck who did not know the greater context of Akasha's will...

"**YOUR REQUEST DOES NOT AMUSE AKASHA.**" Hakur stated. "**ONLY REQUESTS WHICH AMUSE HIM WILL BE FULFILLED. YOUR REQUEST IS TOO BENIGN, LACKING IN INTRIGUE, AND UNINTERESTING BEYOND**

BELIEF. IF YOU DO NOT SPEAK A DIFFERENT REQUEST, I WILL DEPART WITHOUT GRANTING YOU A BOON."

Artorias paled. This was different from what he expected! Uriel had told him that ascending to the 100th step, the 250th step, the 1000th step, and several others beyond that would cause Akasha to grant greater and greater boons to those who succeeded. He never expected that Akasha would have the power to do something, but refuse!

This caused his heart to erupt into turmoil. Artorias paled and looked down, shocked out of his wits.

"A... a moment, great Hakur!" Artorias coughed, his mind racing with fear.

He didn't want to give up this chance to save his brother!

Nobody in the universe mattered more to Artorias. Barbatos was the only family member Artorias cared about, and their bond had grown closer than anyone else could comprehend.

That thought made Artorias realize the truth of the matter.

If Akasha desired amusement, then there was one guaranteed way to amuse him...

"A... sacrifice!" Artorias coughed, looking back up at Hakur. "I wish... for the Highest on High, Akasha... to merge my soul into Barbatos' soul. Kill me so that he may live! Grant him all my strength! Make me my brother's greatest weapon. In exchange, I will give up my life!"

Hakur's expression flickered. A faint smile appeared upon the corners of his mouth.

"**YOU ARE OF ADMIRABLE CHARACTER, ASCENDER FROM THE MILKY WAY. AKASHA IS PLEASED. THIS REQUEST IS WITHIN HIS POWER. HE HAS DECIDED TO GRANT IT. CONGRATULATIONS, AND MY CONDOLENCES. YOUR LIFE SHALL BECOME ANOTHER LINE IN THE GREAT EPIC THAT IS THE 'STORY OF ETERNITIES'. NOW GO, AND BE ONE WITH YOUR BROTHER.**"

Hakur levitated upward, slowly at first. But then, he abruptly accelerated and launched back up toward the top of the Akashic Mountain, vanishing into the clouds.

After he left, Artoria's body began to weaken. The process ramped up over a few seconds, making him feel as if he had become a leaky pot with holes allowing its boiling

water to escape. Artorias sagged forward, collapsing onto the steps. His eyes began to dim, all while Umi levitated over to him and gazed upon his dying form.

"**A useless gesture. You should have seized control of your brother's body and eradicated his soul.**" Umi intoned blandly. "**But this outcome is acceptable as well. My galaxy will obtain another formidable Cosmic.**"

Artorias didn't answer. The light in his eyes dimmed. He closed them, then sighed softly, one last time.

Barbatos... little brother... we have both suffered... but I hope you will... live... on... and never forget... me...

His body dissipated into particles of light, and those particles exited the Cosmic Realm, flying back to the material realm, where Barbatos's body awaited...

"Kill her." Raphael said calmly, as he looked at his sister futilely healing the former body she once had possessed.

Hardly had those words left his mouth before there was an abrupt change. Cosmic Power began radiating from Barbatos's form, and Raphael's eyes widened. He reflexively took a step back as he sensed surging waves of power erupt from Barbatos, the demon transforming from mortal to Cosmic in a matter of seconds!

Barbatos's eyes snapped open. Artorias's soul fragments merged with his, and in turn, the knowledge of what he had done.

A roar of pain, of suffering, of loss, exploded from Barbatos's mouth. He shoved himself off the ground, his bloodshot eyes filling with hatred.

"ARTORIAAAASSSS!!!"

Hot tears flowed from Barbatos's eyes. His heart palpitated with anxiety as the weight of what he had just lost threatened to make his body explode from grief.

His aura rose to the level of High Cosmic, the same as the Archangels. His power reached a level only the tiniest fraction of Sentients could ever hope to attain.

But he was not happy. This development was not desirable.

Barbatos had lost his brother; the only person he had ever truly loved and cared about.

What he gained was far, far from being able to take Artorias's place.

A pitch-black void swallowed Barbatos's heart. That void took physical form when he suddenly sent a surge of darkness out in all directions, stifling the brilliance of the Cosmic Realm with a wall of shadow that plunged the immediate area into darkness.

Raphael's blood ran cold. The rage he sensed from this new opponent was greater than he ever imagined. He had no idea his sister would be able to heal Barbatos and bring him back to life, certainly not so quickly. Too late, he realized her healing abilities must have been massively improved when she was turned into a proper Cosmic.

Barbatos's rage grew hotter and hotter. His darkness began swallowing the Cosmic Realm to such an extent that even the furthest edges the angels could see had disappeared from sight. Only the innate glow of the angels' bodies made them visible. Barbatos's glowing blood-red eyes were all they could perceive of his position.

Uriel spun around and looked at Barbatos in shock. She couldn't believe what had just happened. She had only hoped to heal him and wake him up so he could escape, but instead, he had suddenly become a Cosmic! If that were to happen, which she guessed might be a possibility, she thought he would become a Bottom Cosmic at the highest. That assumption turned out to be completely wrong!

"Barbatos?!" Uriel gasped.

"My brother is DEAD!" Barbatos roared. "He died... from desperation... to keep me alive!"

The newest Demon Deity held his palm up to the sky. Out of nowhere, a massive black greatsword materialized and fell downward, clapping into his palm and forcing his arm downward. The blackened blade struck the floor of the Cosmic Realm with a heavy *thud*, but Barbatos kept his grip steady.

This was Artorias's soulblade. Barbatos had only wielded it a handful of times over the years, as it was created from the power of Artorias's soul. But now... it was hollow and empty.

Artorias's soul had scattered and dissolved. His weapon remained, but he himself was nowhere among the land of the living.

Barbatos gazed upon the massive weapon, feeling the pain of losing a brother, knowing that Artorias had given everything just to keep him alive.

The demon no longer paid attention to Uriel. His attention locked on to Raphael, the one whose machinations had brought Artorias to the brink of desperation.

"RAPHAEL." Barbatos glowered, slowly lifting a finger to point at the eldest Archangel. "You… must… PAAAAY!!"

Part 696: The Wound That Never Heals

Recommended Listening

Far-Future Era. Day 18, AJR. Inside the False Cosmic Realm.

Barbatos's eyes flashed with hatred. A rage he had never experienced before. A sense of grief mixed with self-loathing and pain.

He had sworn to Artorias, an eon earlier, that the two of them would someday reunite in new bodies. He had suffered under Uriel's torture for 100,000 years, all in the hopes of someday reviving his brother.

But now Artorias was lost.

He was gone forever. Dead!

"**RAPHAAEELLL!!!**"

Barbatos lunged at Raphael. His blood red eyes burst with demonic light as he swung Artorias's massive greatsword down, aiming to cleave the Archangel of Wisdom in two.

Gabriel was the first to react. He conjured an equally massive greatsword of light and swung it up to meet the blade of Artorias.

CLANG!!

Two greatswords met. One shattered on impact. Gabriel's blade offered no resistance to Artorias, which had been baptized with the divine power of 163 Akashic Steps!

Artorias cleaved through Gabriel's blade and slammed into the Archangel of Power with enough force to send Gabriel flying! Even with his Hyphyte empowered body, he hadn't spent a single second growing acclimated to his new strength. Gabriel went sprawling, his body careening, twisting, spinning uncontrollably miles into the distance before he came to a stop.

Before Gabriel had even disappeared for a second, Barbatos was already moving toward his next target. Raphael's pupils shrunk as the fully enraged Demon Deity charged at him with reckless abandon.

Raphael was going to die. He had to die! There was no other outcome Barbatos would accept! It was Raphael's evil machinations that led to Artorias sacrificing his existence just to give Barbatos a fighting chance.

"**RAPHAAAEELL!!!**"

Raphael quickly focused his mind. He summoned ten illusory bodies of himself, and they all darted left, right, backward, even leaping into the air to confuse Barbatos. But as Raphael cleverly used the confusion to mix with his false forms, his heart nearly stopped.

Barbatos locked onto Raphael's true body and swung his sword!

"NO!!" Raphael cried in fear.

BOOOM!

Artorias crashed against Raphael and blasted him into the ground, shattering the floor of the False Cosmic Realm and sending spiderweb cracks miles in every direction. The explosive sound was deafening to the point it would have killed any entities below the Cosmic Realm, but fortunately, none were present. Even so, every Archangel heard ringing in their ears.

Raphael was not dead. He was not even seriously injured, but his body ached. His Hyphyte form had truly granted him defensive capabilities beyond reason. Any other High Cosmic would have instantly perished from Barbatos's rage-empowered strike.

The moment Raphael realized he wasn't dead, he scrambled out from under Artorias and scurried away like a cat whose tail had been stomped. Barbatos started to give chase, only for Michael and Uzziel to jump in his path.

"Leave my brother alone, demon!" Uzziel roared.

"I am thy opponent!" Michael added.

But those two suddenly felt another presence lock on to them. Uriel charged into battle, her eyes filled with cold and deadly battle intent.

She realized now, too late, that she had denied the truth for too long.

She had loved Artorias!

Loved him. A demon!

It was an act of sin. Something she never realized until he was already gone.

But it was the truth!!

"Raphael must DIE!!" Uriel shrieked, conjuring a pair of light-spears in her hands.

Uriel was one of the fiercest Archangels. Not only did she possess eons of battle experience, but her powers were diverse and potent. She wielded all four classical elements, plus light magic, plus dark magic, and even Barbatos's magnetism.

Unbeknownst to the other angels, Barbatos wielded all of her powers as well.

It was as if there were two Uriels fighting at the same time!

Blasts of fire illuminated the darkness that had swallowed the Cosmic Realm. Uriel spun her spears around, crashing against Michael's longsword and Uzziel's vine-whips. They had no time to protect Raphael, because their opponent was even more frightening than his!

"All of thee art traitors to life itself!" Uriel shouted. "Monsters serving monsters! Thy lives art no longer worthy of continuing!"

"Sister! Come back to the light!" Michael urged. He hurriedly whipped his sword in a wide arc to deflect her spears. "Do not fall for the lies of a bloodskin!"

Michael's usage of a slur enraged Uriel even more. She, who had once cavalierly used such words, now felt they were a personal affront to her fallen comrade. The man she loved!

"BASTARD!" Uriel shouted.

As Uriel fought Michael and Uzziel, Barbatos continued chasing after Raphael. The old man no longer held any resemblance to a wise old sage. He looked like a rat that had hopped out of a fire! His beard was singed and cut apart, with chunks missing. He ran as fast as he could, trying to confuse Barbatos or throw him off his trail, but the demon doggedly pursued him! It seemed Barbatos could see right through all of Raphael's tricks.

Fire exploded from Artorias. The greatsword cut down at Raphael, who dove to the side and barely evaded the hammer-like impact of the sword striking the blackened ground. The Cosmic Realm seemed to groan in pain as Barbatos chopped and sliced at Raphael, doing his damnedest to kill the old man as quickly as possible.

Finally, Gabriel rejoined the fight. He was much bigger than anyone present, and far stronger than his eldest brother. Now better comprehending Barbatos's strength, Gabriel charged at him and used his body as a living weapon. He punched Barbatos's head and

knocked him backward, then slapped Artorias aside with a quick backhand before grabbing at Barbatos's throat.

Barbatos ducked and dodged Gabriel's clumsy grab. He spun on his heel, then thrust the long hilt of Artorias into Gabriel's stomach, knocking the wind out of him. Gabriel momentarily lost his balance, so Barbatos leaped into the air, spun his leg around, and delivered a brutal whirlwind kick into Gabriel's solar plexus. This time, Gabriel didn't go flying nearly as far, but he was still sent sprawling on his ass.

By this point, Raphael had made some distance. He turned around to face Barbatos, who had started charging again. Raphael's expression became one of a cornered animal. He sneered viciously and snarled like a rabid dog.

"Dost thou thinketh me the type to merely run away?! Fool! Thou shalt learn to fear the old!"

Raphael charged at Barbatos. Two images of Raphael split apart and rushed him in unison. When Raphael and Barbatos collided, it turned out that these illusory images were not illusions at all, but physical projections!

The impact sent both the demon and the Archangel crashing to the ground! It was as if two cars had slammed into each other at full speed, causing their bodies to twist together. With Raphael's newfound Hyphyte body, he discovered he could take hits like Bael and still come out the other side kicking.

Barbatos, meanwhile, was much worse off. When he slammed into Raphael and his projections, the impact broke Barbatos's left arm and caused him to lose his grip on Artorias. The sword clattered to the ground, and Barbatos fell to one knee, clutching his arm.

Raphael sneered. It turned out he had been afraid of nothing! Barbatos might be angry, but rage meant nothing in the face of the Hyphytes!

Raphael jumped to his feet. Just before he started to move toward Barbatos, the Demon Deity used his right hand to summon... divine light!

Raphael was momentarily baffled, completely tongue-tied, when he saw Barbatos wield Uriel's power and heal himself! Barbatos regenerated his wound in less than a second and shoved his broken bone back into place, fully mending it and returning to his

previous fighting form. He grabbed Artorias and jumped up, charging at Raphael as if he hadn't just suffered a loss during their previous collision.

Raphael shot Uriel a venomous glare while she battled Michael and Uzziel. He couldn't believe his eyes, but it seemed she had truly fallen further than he ever imagined. She had even granted a fragment of her powers to this bloodskin.

Blasphemous woman!

Raphael and Barbatos once again collided. Gabriel joined the fight, and together, the two brothers began pushing Barbatos back.

Time and time again, the two of them gained an upper hand and beat Barbatos into a pulp, but he quickly healed his injuries before they could finish him off.

Sometimes, Barbatos slammed one of the two Archangels down, using the oppressive power of his sword. Artorias had become a fearsome weapon, just as hardy and durable as the Hyphyte bodies these Archangels controlled, but with more cutting power than any weapons they could conjure. Constructs of light could barely slow down the blade, let alone deflect or stop it entirely. Gabriel found that only his bare hands and fists were capable of stopping Artorias's might, but Gabriel lacked Uriel's healing powers, and the collisions always left him slightly worse off.

Slowly, a war of attrition unfolded. Barbatos had the better weapon, but the worse body. He compensated by constantly healing himself, while his enemies could not.

"Die already, bastard!" Raphael cried in anger. "How can thy body persist after such punishment?!"

"**YOUR PAIN HAS ONLY JUST BEGUN, OLD WRETCH!**" Barbatos roared.

Barbatos slammed Artorias against Raphael, pounding the old man downward and causing his bones to creak. Gabriel slammed the flat of a conjured greatsword against Barbatos's back and sent him sprawling. Their brutal melee only intensified!

At the same time, Uriel fought Michael and Uzziel with equal fervor. Despite her and Barbatos being outnumbered two to one, Raphael and Uzziel were not at the level of Barbatos and Michael. Uzziel in particular was a terrible combatant with an awful battle sense. Even after regaining her Primordial memories, she had not become much more fearsome than her Ancient Era self. This was because Uzziel had always been an

insidious, poisonous schemer. Not a battle maniac like Uriel, Michael, Gabriel, and Camael.

As for Michael, his ability to wield a sword was extremely focused and practiced. His mastery of the blade far exceeded Uriel's mastery of the twin spears, but she more than made up for it with her diverse powerset.

In Michael's eyes, Uriel's weapons whipped up a storm, but moved slowly enough for him to follow and counteract. He swept his right arm around like a hurricane, deflecting one attack after another. He carefully protected Uzziel, while she conjured vines to entrap Uriel's legs and slow her down.

Uzziel looked more irritated than fearful. She looked over and saw that the battle against Barbatos was not going particularly well. It seemed that over time, Barbatos's rage and healing factor was giving him an edge even against two Hyphyte-empowered Archangels.

"Enough of this!" Uzziel spat. "Uriel, I shalt grant thee one final chance to see the light! Join us, or perish!"

Uriel snarled viciously. "Thou art equal in evil deeds to Raphael! Perish here, witch!"

Uzziel snorted. "So be it."

She waved her hand. All at once, Uriel's body froze. She lost her grip on her spears, and they went flying. Michael didn't even have a chance to react before his sword cut across Uriel's neck, struck her hardened Hyphyte skin, and sent her toppling backward.

Uriel lost all the strength in her body. She fell to the ground, unable to move. Agony coursed through her veins, causing her to spasm.

"Ah- ahh! Ahh!" Uriel cried out pitifully.

Michael didn't immediately move to finish her life. He instead stared in bewilderment. "What... what is the meaning behind this? How dids't thou render her helpless, Uzziel?"

He looked at his sister. She met his gaze and snorted. "'Tis none of thy concern. Kill her now, while she is unable to retort!"

Michael didn't move. He instead looked at Uzziel for a few seconds, then seemed to realize something.

"These... these Hyphyte bodies! Thou hath corrupted them! Poisoned them! Dost this mean thou cans't render any of us helpless at will, too?!"

Uzziel glowered at Michael. "That's right. Is there a problem, big brother? Dost thou believeth me to be a blackheart who would use this power on thee? I only used it on Uriel because of her obstinance! Now we can end her threat, and the bloodskin as well! Thou shoulds't be thanking me."

Michael's glare became more focused. He realized that Uzziel hadn't told any of her brothers or sister about this backdoor because she must have been planning to use it on them if they ever turned against her.

In particular, Raphael was the one she feared the most...

"Kill her thyself if thou wisheth." Michael spat. "I shalt not execute my sister while she art helpless. This goes against my way!"

"Bah. If thou art such a coward, then we mayest deal with her later." Uzziel said. "Right now, 'tis Raphael and Gabriel who need our help. That bloodskin is proving quite formidable. As for Uriel, she was never a threat."

"Because thou were capable of shutting her down from the very beginning." Michael said, directing another pointed glare at his sister. "I do not approve of thy new, insidious self."

"'Tis not new. 'Tis how I hath always acted." Uzziel replied slyly.

The two of them left Uriel laying on the ground. Unable to move, she could only gasp in pain and writhe uncontrollably, fighting for her life to try and break free of Uzziel's trickery.

If Uriel had known these Hyphyte bodies were trapped from the beginning, she never would have crossed over! Uzziel had fooled everyone. Once the battle ended, the other Archangels would not be able to look at her with any semblance of trust. But neither could they resist her will! She had played the long game... and won.

Barbatos's rage kept him focused on his single-minded goal of killing Raphael. But even so, he was shocked when he sensed the approach of Michael and Uzziel.

Where was Uriel? Why wasn't she keeping them under control? Had those two somehow gotten the upper hand on her?

Barbatos didn't have time to think. He quickly jumped backward right as two more Archangels joined the fight.

This time, he was in the absolute worst position. Fighting Raphael and Gabriel was difficult, but winnable. Raphael couldn't present much threat, but he offered solid backup for his much stronger brother. Raphael's ability to ensnare and trick other beings was his greatest supporting asset in a team battle. Once Uzziel arrived, that support role doubled, and Michael added another powerhouse to the team.

Two on one was barely doable. Four on one was a complete wash! Barbatos didn't stand a chance.

As Gabriel hammered Barbatos from the front and Michael struck him from the back, Uzziel snared him with vines and Raphael pummeled him with projections. Barbatos reeled. He couldn't continue his offensive and was firmly forced back on the defense.

"No! NO!!" Barbatos roared, his words filled with rage and regret. He swept his sword, but Gabriel dodged and struck him in the face. He stabbed at Michael, but Michael ducked the attack and plunged a blade of light into Barbatos's heart.

"Gah! Guhuk! Urrggh!!"

It was unfair. It was brutal.

The Archangels relentlessly used their numerical and bodily superiority to thrash Barbatos. When he swung Artorias, Michael swiftly cut at his wrist to sever Barbatos's hand! The sword flew into the distance, and Barbatos cried in pain. A dozen sword slashes cut his armored back, carving out bloody rivers of blood to flow from behind.

A mighty punch from Gabriel blasted Barbatos's face and sent him flying. He crashed onto the ground and slid away, his dark domain finally losing its power.

Light returned to the False Cosmic Realm. Barbatos choked and coughed up blood. As the Archangels approached, his vision dimmed.

He had failed.

He couldn't avenge Artorias's death.

Raphael would go free. Free to torment others. To genocide entire species and lay claim to the galaxy. To bring about the end of more brothers, mothers, fathers and sisters alike.

His wicked machinations would persist, long after Barbatos's death.

As the Archangels closed in, Barbatos's eyes flicked to his brother's sword. Now laying inert a hundred yards away, Barbatos lacked the strength to run over and grab it.

"You... angel.. bastards..." Barbatos coughed. "Bloodless villains... monsters of the primordial world... you should have... died... long ago."

"Sadly for thee, we did not." Raphael said coolly. "Verily, we shalt outlast thy pitiful species. The angels' rise will continue, unabated. All of creation shalt recall our majesty. Thou art merely the first to die, baptizing our future rise with thy blood."

"Well said, Raphael." Uzziel added.

Michael looked disturbed. He hated demons more then many of the others, but even he thought this whole affair was somewhat... *barbaric*.

Raphael gestured at Gabriel. "Finish him."

Gabriel nodded. He took a step forward and conjured a new greatsword.

A spike of energy from the left caught Gabriel's attention. He flinched when he saw something flying toward him at high speeds. Uriel crashed her body into Gabriel and slammed him aside, sending him hurtling to the right. The other Archangels gasped when they saw their sister standing once again.

Raphael hadn't seen how Uriel was incapacitated, since he wasn't present for Uzziel's secret ability, but he had assumed Uriel was crippled beyond repair. It turned out that belief was wrong!

"Keep away from him, ye bunch of murderous fiends!" Uriel barked, her eyes flaring with hatred. She assumed a defensive stance in front of Barbatos, shielding him with her body. "Hath the lot of thee not done enough?!"

"Thy body regained its vigor?" Uzziel asked, somewhat baffled. "Impossible!"

"The pain thou inflicted meaneth little to I who have suffered in agony for an eon!" Uriel proclaimed. "I broke thy serpentine hold with contemptuous ease, just as I shalt soon break thy bodies and spirits alike!"

"Thou art outnumbered, sister." Raphael said coldly. "Nothing has changed. We shalt eliminate this bloodskin first, then we shalt execute thee for siding with thy enemies."

A tense standoff followed. Despite Raphael's bold proclamation, the other Archangels didn't immediately make a move.

Michael's faith wavered. Killing Barbatos was one thing. He didn't give a damn about the demon in the slightest. In fact, for taking Uriel away, Michael hated his guts!

But at the same time, Michael felt no hatred for Uriel. She had been trapped inside of Barbatos for an eon, and she had suffered more pain than anyone deserved. Michael felt only sadness for her fate.

Then, the situation changed.

Gabriel stepped forward. He held his greatsword aloft, causing Uriel to take a step back and cross her spears defensively.

But Gabriel did not attack. As soon as he raised his greatsword, he turned to face the other Archangels, leaving his back to Uriel.

"This... is... wrong." Gabriel said, his words slow and ponderous. "I can no longer go along with these wicked deeds."

"What?!" Raphael exclaimed. "Gabriel! Hath thou turneth traitor as well?! Art thou an ally of the bloodskins?!"

Gabriel gave his eldest brother a pointed but emotionless stare. There was neither hostility nor love in his gaze.

"I care not what happens to the demon. However, it has become apparent to me that he is precious to my sister. I cannot in good conscience bring my blade to fall upon Barbatos knowing the emotional pain Uriel will suffer."

Gabriel swept his gaze across the three opposing Archangels.

"Verily, I never agreed to thy conditions. I never wished to bring harm upon my family members." Gabriel said coldly. "These schemes, these lies... how deep doth thy prejudice fall, Raphael? How wicked art thy heart, Uzziel? When I learneth thy mind was still sound and thy body intact, I felt joy aplenty. But now, I feel only sorrow and regret."

Gabriel waved a hand from left to right.

"Look upon this realm. This corrupted once-holy bastion of divinity. What Cosmic Realm? What sanctuary for our people? It doth be little more than a breeding ground for heresy!"

"Silence!" Raphael shouted, his face momentarily turning red with anger. "What little doth thou know? Thou dids't agree, at the end of the Primordial Era, to this scheme! All of thee did! How cans't thee now turn thy backs on the great plan to swallow the galaxy? What demons? What humans? What Volgrim? These petty creatures mean nothing! They art little more than vermin in our eyes!!"

Michael slowly nodded. He didn't hate Uriel, and indeed he didn't want her to die at all, but in his eyes, Raphael made a good point. Why should he care about the rest of the galaxy when it never cared about him?

But Gabriel was unmoved. Raphael's words fell upon deaf ears.

"Is that all? I will not say that I hold much love for the weak mortals that have taken up residence in the galaxy, but neither do I hate them. They are as benign to me as birds and cows from old Earth. I do not wish to exterminate them, and thus, I must stand in opposition to thee."

Raphael fell silent. He turned to look at Michael, and they gazed into one another's eyes for a few brief moments.

"Michael. What say thee in response to thy brother and sister's words?" Raphael asked pointedly.

"I... do not wish to kill Uriel." Michael said. "Nor do I wish to see Gabriel fall. Is there no other way we can bring about a new era?"

In his heart, Michael realized that he was completely torn between Raphael and Gabriel. He couldn't decide which one had the better point, but he knew for a fact that he emotionally resonated more with Gabriel.

Raphael... simply wasn't trustworthy.

Raphael exchanged a glance with Uzziel. He looked away and snorted.

"How pitiful. All these years spent thinking about the joy we woulds't experience once reunited, but in the end, only one of my siblings remembered that family takes precedence over morality."

Raphael sighed. "What a shame. What a shame."

Michael sensed something changing in Raphael's tone. He carefully stepped toward Gabriel's side, then turned to stare with distrust at Raphael.

"Brother Raphael?" Michael asked.

Raphael did not respond. He merely stood taller, then crossed his arms.

"They art lost, Uzziel. Kill them all."

"Yes." Uzziel nodded.

At once, a strange sense of pressure grabbed hold of Barbatos, Uriel, Michael, and Gabriel's minds. Their breathing became stifled as the presence of thousands, million, billions of life-forms came flooding toward them from a great distance away.

"No!" Michael shouted, half from fear, half from disbelief. "Raphael! How coulds't thee?!"

From all across the False Cosmic Realm, countless Hyphytes, as numerous as the drops of water in an ocean, began rushing toward the Archangels. While none of them were High Cosmics, a few were Middle Cosmics, and there were still thousands and thousands of Low Cosmics. Together, combined with their unbreakable bodies, they formed an unstoppable flood that was bearing down on the rogue Archangels.

"Sister!" Gabriel shouted. "Take that demon and go! I shalt hold them off!"

"So too shalt I!" Michael added, only to grimace at the realization he was working to save a damned demon. "Go!"

Uriel realized the end was drawing near. After less than a second's hesitation, she turned around, scooped up Barbatos, then tossed his injured body over her shoulder.

"Do not die!" Uriel shouted at Michael and Gabriel. "I command both of thee!"

She flapped her wings and launched into the air, grabbing Artorias's blade before racing to find an exit to the Cosmic Realm, even as her brothers stood firm against Raphael and Uzziel both.

As for what fate befell Michael and Gabriel, that was something Barbatos did not know.

All he knew was... he had failed. His brother was dead. Artorias had fallen to uplift Barbatos, but now the younger of the brothers was left alone, no family anywhere in the world.

How could he possibly deal with his own grief, knowing what he had lost?

How could he?

Part 697: Galactic Unification

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Numaria.

A dozen Demon Emperors, as well as Demon Deity Auger and a few others of his rank, listened to Barbatos's tale with solemn expressions. The revelation that their greatest enemy and the galaxy's current crisis were one and the same had a terrible effect on their moods. If before they had a feeling that they might be able to beat the Plague by allying with the Dolgrimites, now they were under no such illusions.

Auger swallowed heavily. "And what of Uriel? She fled with you from the Cosmic Realm, so why isn't she here?"

Barbatos coughed. He had yet to regenerate his missing hand, and his body was in such bad shape that even with Belial healing him night and day, it might take a full week for him to get back into fighting form, or at least to the point he could heal himself.

"We were... assaulted... by Kolvaxians. The entire way back." Barbatos said haltingly. "Uriel fought with great fury. She summoned her Light Constructs to beat back the hordes, but they were numerous beyond belief. I blacked out, then I awoke here."

"Uriel must have sent you to Hell Harbor." Yardrat said, his astral form hovering beside Auger. "Perhaps she launched you away and used some method to hide your Cosmic signature so the Plague would lose track of you."

"The odds are high that Uriel is either dead or has been captured." Auger said. "But this is hardly the worst news Barbatos has brought us."

Auger turned around to look at all the other Emperors.

"All of us have been deceived. The Plague is not a mindless super-organism. It is a creation of Archangel Uzziel. It is a bio-weapon used to convert us into her thralls. Worst of all, she is a High Cosmic now, along with the other Archangels. Uriel may have now aligned herself with our interests, but compared to the trillions of Plaguehosts lurking in the Cosmic Realm, her assistance will be minimal at best."

"What about Michael and Gabriel?" Belial interjected. "They stood with their sister. A force of three High Cosmic Archangels assisting us, along with Barbatos-"

"Will not be enough." Yardrat interrupted, shaking his head. "I believe we only have one choice left to us, now. We must retreat. All of demonkind must enter the Labyrinth. We must disable the Warpgates and hide there, in the dark, unable to leave. If we do not, we will lose the war the moment Uzziel looses her unending legion of 'Hyphytes' upon us."

"Why did she not do so sooner?" Emperor Leeroy pointedly asked. "If Uzziel has always had the ability to launch an all-out assault, why hasn't she?"

Auger chuckled dryly.

"The answer is simple." Auger said softly. "In her eyes, she has already won. She *could* obliterate all of us, but she hasn't. Why? Because she is toying with us. Slowly stoking the flames of fear in our hearts. Snuffing out our hope. Pushing us to the brink of despair."

"Revenge." Yardrat added. "This entire war is about her exacting her revenge. She wants us all to suffer, weep, and cry as her forces continually push us inward. And now that her plot has been exposed, she might show up in the next hour and announce our executions. We have no way of fighting back."

"The HELL we don't!" Belial barked, startling everyone around her. "We do have a way to fight back! You just aren't using your heads!"

Auger looked at her with disapproval. "Samantha, there is no reason to speak useless words. You cannot win against an army of unending, nigh-invincible monsters using mere bravado."

"Then I guess you're not all that bright, Auger." Belial snapped at him. "I think we can win this war. I think if we all unite together, humans, demons, and Volgrim, along with the monsters, we might be able to find a genuine solution to wipe out the Plague, once and for all!"

"All our species uniting? What difference would that make?" Yardrat asked. "The Volgrim have had 100,000 years to come up with a method for counteracting the Plague. They failed, and that was before the Plague was empowered by the Wordsmith. Now the situation is utterly unwinnable."

Several demon leaders nodded. The look of dejection in their eyes was palpable.

"Samantha." Auger said, walking over to rest a palm on her shoulder. "Perhaps if the Wordsmith were still alive, we might stand a chance. But he is not. Our best shot of

wiping out the Plague was before it became empowered by Artoria, when Diablo still roamed the cosmos. Without him, and without the Wordsmith, who can possibly save us?"

Belial pulled away from Auger's touch and looked at him in disgust.

"So that's it? The war isn't over, but you're going to throw in the towel? Just like that? Where's your courage? Your sense of pride? Has it occurred to you that maybe the Plague isn't as powerful as it seems? Maybe the real reason Uzziel hasn't wiped out all life in the galaxy is because the Plague is not as formidable as it first appears."

The other demons simply stared at Belial. Impassioned her words might sound, but they seemed to lack in logic...

"Think about it!" Belial shouted, raising her voice so everyone could hear. "If Uzziel is the mother of these creatures, the queen, the Plague's primary controller, then try putting yourself in her shoes. Do you really think she has the capability to individually control trillions of Plaguehosts all by herself? No, let me do you one better. Do you think she can even control a thousand Plaguehosts by herself? With perfect precision? The same as if she were controlling her own body?"

Auger blinked. "Where are you going with this?"

"I'm going exactly where you think I'm going." Belial retorted. She stretched out her arm and turned it into a long sharp blade, then began scraping the floor to draw a crude diagram. "Look here. We knew of a human Hero, Jepthath, who could combine the minds of his soldiers to allow them to fight with extreme teamwork. We also know that you, Auger, can combine the powers of demons who have pledged themselves to you, passing them around and distributing them as needed. Don't these powers sound similar to what Uzziel is doing?"

Auger chewed his lower lip. "Indeed. I suppose, if we assume that her powers are somehow similar to mine and Jepthath's..."

"Then we might also be able to assume that one mind, *her* mind, is far from capable of controlling all those Plaguehosts with the same precision as each of us controlling our own bodies." Belial explained. "That could be a weakness we might be able to exploit!"

Auger no longer looked so skeptical. He stroked his beard as he looked at the drawings Belial had made of a distributed brain-sharing network.

"You might be on to something." Auger said. "But this is still mere conjecture."

"We need to inform the humans and the Volgrim." Belial said. "Only by working together do we stand a chance against this threat."

This time, many demons nodded along to her words.

Facing a relatively unintelligent hivemind enemy was one thing. But knowing there was a central intelligence behind that hive was very different. If Uzziel now had Raphael's counsel, she might start to move quickly. They could suffer an assault by the Kolvaxians by day's end. Perhaps even sooner!

Auger hesitated for only a moment before nodding.

"Yardrat. Open a portal back to Sharmur. Samantha, I'll need to trouble you to explain the situation to Commander Adams. Linda should be more receptive if you're the one explaining the situation."

"And what about the rest of you?" Belial asked.

"I am going to personally confer with Founder Unarin." Auger said. "Yardrat, you will speak in my stead to the Dolgrimites. I want all the rest of you to fan out to the various monster-controlled worlds and deliver this news to all of them. I want everyone brought up to speed on the truth behind the Kolvaxians within the next two hours!"

Yardrat stood tall, his wirey frame seeming to hold a deep importance now that his portalling ability would be key in mobilizing the other demons to spread news around their allies as quickly as possible.

"Yes, Lord Auger. We move at your command."

Without delay, the different demons began fanning out. Belial returned to Sharmur, Yardrat sent many demons to worlds such as Pixiv to confer with the fairies, the orcs, the goblins, and dozen of other species.

No longer could the demons maintain even the slightest facade of hostility. The stakes were too high. One of their own had crippled the Volgrim, which meant they had even fewer powerful allies capable of tackling the Kolvaxian threat. If it weren't for Mephisto and Demila's betrayal, the Volgrim would have plenty of Cosmics available to help stymie the inevitable assault of the Kolvaxians, once Uzziel deemed the time right to make her move.

What Auger did not know was that, in secret, one of his kind were secretly about to cause another great tragedy that could destabilize the entire situation out of his control...

Not much earlier that day...

A massive figure lumbered through the Labyrinth's corridors, moving quickly to the Core. This figure was well-known among any who witnessed her. Her bright blue feathers alone were striking enough to catch anyone's eye.

Emperor Crow had a savage gleam barely contained within her eyes. She had finally pieced together the last bit of a conspiracy; one she was determined to bring to an end today. No matter the cost.

She did not stick around long enough to hear the story of what had happened to Barbatos. But neither did she care. She was 'only' an Emperor. Compared to the lauded Demon Deities, she stood at the peak of the mortal world, but this mattered little to those in power. Where once she was a terrifying figure every other demon worshiped, now she was but a pawn in the eyes of those who had surpassed her.

Crow was not enraged regarding this fact. True, it was unfortunate, but she did not let it bother her. She simply stopped caring about running things, and allowed herself to fade into the background.

Ever since she had fought with a mysterious angel on the Queen Network, one that the other demons thought might be Uriel or Camael, she had long realized the truth behind that angel's identity.

She was the Daughter of Heaven. A Lazarite! The murderer of Red Raven!!

How she had survived this long was a mystery Crow did not know the answer to. But neither did she care. That angel was the one who had cut down Crow's husband, a demon she loved more than life itself. A hundred thousand years had passed, but her life had lost its brightness. Every day that passed, she felt more and more like a shadow of her former self.

Without Red Raven, Crow felt that she had become a husk. She sought power through rituals, but she no longer knew why. She sought to become stronger, but the meaning behind such actions had long faded into memory.

But that was then, and this was now!

She suddenly felt her spark of life reignite!

Hatred!

All-encompassing hatred!!

She had a reason to continue on! She could find the bitch who murdered her husband, capture her, lock her in a dungeon, and torture her for the rest of eternity!

The Daughter of Heaven would spend the rest of her life screaming, crying, begging for mercy, and Crow would never allow her a moment of comfort ever again!!

Crow's beak gnashed together as she felt heat radiating from her feathers. She was fired up with rage in the most literal way possible, to the point her body had warmed considerably.

When she stormed into the Core, the demons present took immediate notice. They quickly got the hell out of her way, easily picking up on the fact that she seemed furious about something.

What had made her so mad? They didn't know! They didn't want to know, either! It was none of their business.

The last demon who had casually yapped at Crow had ended up a puddle of meat and gore on the floor. Nobody bothered her after that.

* * *

Crow arrived at the Warpgate leading to Sharmur. The goblins operating it quickly shivered with fear when she looked at them. Without hesitation, they opened the warpgate and allowed Crow to pass through.

The moment Crow arrived on the other side, a pair of human guards stationed on the right and left lifted their weapons to aim at her.

"Halt! Emperor Crow, you are not on the authorized entry list! What is your reason for coming here?"

The humans did not have the greatest relationship with the Seven Hells. Even though nominally they were supposed to be working together, the humans did not trust the demons, and the demons did not value the humans much. True, the humans had some useful technologies, but the deaths of both Wordsmiths had made their species feel rather... limited.

Thus, when Crow arrived, the guards immediately tensed up. Crow directed a withering glare at both of them, then she stomped toward the one on the right and leered toward him, ignoring the 'threat' his gun posed, as it genuinely could not hurt her at all.

"My business here is mine." Crow hissed. "Both of you would do well you keep your mouths *shut* regarding my arrival. I have noted your scents, which not even that fancy armor can hide. If anyone should bother me, I will return and dispose of you both. Do I make myself *clear*?"

The guard whose personal space she had blatantly invaded began to shake and tremble. Crow was absolutely massive. Not only was she regarded as the physically strongest Emperor, but her body was a living weapon. Even without using a Ritual, Crow was capable of ripping apart human tanks with great ease. It was as if she had slowly become a primordial bird of prey, one whose presence dwarfed mountains.

When Crow was pissed, everyone took notice.

The trembling guard tried to maintain his dignity. He truly did. But his weak and shaking voice did nothing to improve his composure.

"Y-you should, um, s-s-speak with D-Deity Melody and m-make an app... app... appoint...ment?"

Crow said nothing. She simply took a step closer, and the strength went out in the man's legs. He crumpled to his butt and shivered in fear.

"W-we won't say a-anything... just... just go on... ahead... and have a n-n-nice day... M-M-Miss Crow..."

Crow snorted. She glanced at the other guard, who quickly lowered his weapon, shook his head, and looked away. He did not want to mess with her in her clearly awful mood.

Crow flapped her wings. She launched into the air and stayed low to the ground, careful to keep out of the eye of anyone who might spot and report her.

After she left, the traumatized guard shakily stood up. His friend came over to help him.

"Should we... tell Command?"

"No way! Are you kidding?! If Crow tries anything, Melody will know. Just keep your trap shut so we don't end up like the last guy who pissed her off. That Crow is a loose cannon!!"

"Yeah... good point. We didn't see anything."

* * *

Crow flew low to the ground. She eventually landed on the southern side of the city, but took a few minutes to stop and think.

She didn't know where the Daughter of Heaven was hiding, but she knew what she generally looked like. Brown hair was quite common among the humans, but the fact that she was young and she had a black-haired friend with her had also been mentioned by Vespera. Most importantly, Crow had a name.

"Cammy..."

Crow was an extremely powerful Emperor. Physically, by all accounts, but few knew that she had excellent senses in many other regards. She could be stealthy when she wished.

The midday sun shone on the city of Melodia. Crow's bright blue feathers were fairly eye-catching, but her vision was far beyond that of an eagle. She carefully perched atop a tower, hiding in its shadow and dimming her aura down as much as possible. With her keen eyes, she rapidly swept the city from top to bottom.

She spotted plenty of brown-haired women all over Melodia, but none of them matched Vespera's description. Importantly, few of them were paired with black-haired female friends. So she kept looking, and looking, and looking some more.

Fifteen minutes passed. Crow frowned. It was possible the Daughter of Heaven was hiding inside a building, but based on what Vespera had mentioned just before Crow left, Belial had been hanging out with the two other 'servant girls' out in a forest somewhere.

If Belial were still there, Crow could triangulate her position by sensing her Emperor mana signature. She wasn't now, but maybe there would be residual traces...

Crow thought for a moment. Then she remembered that as a succubi, Belial liked to wear aromatic perfume to spice up her sex appeal. A stupid and fruitless effort, Crow thought, but one that might prove useful to the Emperor of Sacrifice now.

Crow sniffed the air. She sneaked around from rooftop to rooftop, carefully sniffing for Belial's scent. Eventually, she picked it up, as well as traces of her Emperor aura.

Bit by bit, Crow slinked around to the northern side of the city, where the scent became palpable. She eventually flew out of the city limits to the forest, where she hear a

distant crashing sound that abruptly went silent.

The sound of battle? Crow wondered. *Why did they stop? Did someone sense me?*

She spotted a clearing in the distance, in the middle of some trees. As she flew overhead, her pupils dilated. There were two human women looking up at her. One of them had brown hair, the other had black!

It's THEM! Crow thought hungrily, as she immediately dive-bombed into the clearing and slammed claws-first into the center of the arena.

BOOOM!

Crow's landing sent out a shockwave that sent both women tumbling backward. Surprisingly, or perhaps not so surprisingly, they maintained their footing and didn't fall onto their backs. They looked at Crow with a mixture of shock and horror.

Crow cackled deep in the back of her throat. She rose to her full height, towering over both women.

"Heh heh heh... tell me... which one of you is 'Cammy'? I've come to deliver a message from Belial..."

"Forgive us, Lady Crow!" The black haired girl said, quickly getting in front of her brown-haired friend. "We are but humble servants. We do not wish to experience any trouble..."

Crow's eyes held a ruthless light. "Mere servants, eh? Then why is it you were able to sense my presence when so many humans before you could not? Give me 'Cammy' and I'll let you live, stupid little girl."

The black haired girl shivered with fear, but she still stood strong and didn't back down. Even an idiot could tell that she was willing to protect the brown-haired girl with her life.

A few seconds passed. Nobody said anything.

Crow snorted. "It's your funeral, then."

She suddenly stormed toward the girls and lifted her wing to swat the black-haired pest aside.

But before her wing could connect, the look of fear in the black-haired girl's eyes vanished.

"So you want to do things the hard way." Serra said.

WHAM.

Crow saw light dancing in her eyes. Something hit her head with such speed and force that she was sent flying to the right, crashing, careening, bouncing into the treeline before she struck a boulder and her momentum came to a screeching halt.

Three seconds passed. Crow blinked a few times, shocked out of her wits. The blow had been so unexpected that she hadn't raised her guard at all. Was it the black-haired girl? How strong was she? WHO was she, really?!

Crow roared with hatred. She leaped out of the ditch her body had dug and flew back into the arena, where both girls had dropped the facade. Now, the Daughter of Heaven had donned a suit of light armor that hid her physical appearance, but the white wings on her back clearly marked her as an angel!

And even more shockingly, the other girl was also an angel. She didn't even bother hiding her face... yet Crow had no idea who she was.

Crow gasped in shock. "A Lazarite and a Pureblood still walk the mortal plane?! Impossible! You, pureblood, who are you?!"

"My name is Soleil." Soleil said with eerie calmness. "I will protect my lady with my life."

Cassiel stood to her side and glowered at Crow from within her helmet.

"So you've finally come." Cassiel said. "I knew this day would arrive. Ever since I fought you in the Queen Network..."

"How respectable. You actually have the guts to admit it was you." Crow said with a sneer. She glanced at Soleil. "And you're not half bad. You knocked me for a loop, and that takes quite a bit of strength. But in the end, you're merely a roadblock in the way of my *true* prey."

"We shall see about that." Soleil answered stoically.

Author note: It's been ages since I posted any art of a character, but here is artwork of Cassiel in her normal and armored form. I thought you guys

might enjoy it. Based on the artwork a human artist drew, I used Nano Banana to mock her up in a satisfactorily cool set of holy armor as well!

Original Cassiel Image

Cassiel Normal Form

Cassiel Armored Form

Part 698: Alone Again

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Northern Melodia.

Soleil and Crow leaped at one another. The Black Hole Construct swung her fist at Crow and knocked her head aside with the sound of iron crashing against steel. Crow retorted with a violent punch to Soleil's stomach that deformed her abdomen.

Soleil spin-kicked Crow. Crow absorbed the kick with a raised arm, then retorted with a pointed jab at Soleil's face.

In less than a minute, the two unstoppable machines of war beat and battered each other with enough power to level the nearby forest. The arena around them cracked and splintered, with flecks of stone and jagged rocks breaking off and flying out in all directions.

At the same time, Cassiel did not remain idle. She took care to avoid taking Crow on directly, since a single punch from the Emperor would definitely shatter her light armor, maybe even killing her on the spot. Instead, she took potshots at Crow, aiming to hamper her vision, trip up her feet, and slow down the impact of her fists.

Cassiel summoned a powerful rifle made of divine energy, one that originated from the 21st century, near the end of the Energy Wars. She launched bullets at small fractions the speed of light, each one striking Crow's armored feathers like cannonballs. Crow was too busy dealing with Soleil to deal with Cassiel, thus she could only take the hits passively, grunting when each one struck.

"Hahaha!" Crow cackled evilly, as blood dripped down her face into her beak. "You two are interesting! Much too interesting!! Where did a pair of monsters like you manage to hide all these years, eh??"

Crow loved to fight. She loved it more than life itself. She was a battle-maniac. Over the past 100,000 years, she had challenged just about every other Emperor and forced them to admit she was the superior combatant. In a one-on-one fight, she was practically unbeatable.

Of course, this depended on what the definition of a 'fight' or 'winning' was. She had always fought in the past to prove her martial supremacy.

This was a battle to the death, at least for her opponents. Crow didn't care about leaving Soleil alive, but she did want to capture Cassiel intact.

Cassiel and Soleil, on the other hand, knew they needed to kill Crow. Simply beating her unconscious wouldn't be good enough. She would definitely return to fight them again, and would never give up until she'd had her revenge.

Crow hammered Soleil, and Soleil viciously struck back. Time and time again, Crow was shocked out of her wits. She'd never fought such a fierce angel in all her life! Even the legendary Gabriel paled in comparison to this absolute monster! Whoever Soleil was, it was clear she had been a secret weapon the angels never unleashed. Otherwise, there was no chance she wouldn't have become feared by the other demons!

"Who are you?!" Crow roared, after blasting Soleil's face with another brutal punch. "Why have I never heard your name before?!"

Soleil's face sunk in unnaturally, as if she were made of play-doh. Her face popped back out, seemingly uninjured; a fact which startled Crow yet again. Was it possible Soleil wasn't an angel after all? Her 'holy energy' was pitiful beyond belief. She had not demonstrated a single iota of magical power, relying entirely on her physical body to do battle with the Demon Emperor of Sacrifice.

"I prefer not to make my existence known." Soleil said simply, before blasting Crow's stomach with enough force to dent dozens of her feathers and momentarily double her over in pain. Crow's wheezing cries came as a welcome symphony of pain for Soleil.

Crow's eyes flickered with hatred. Another bullet impact struck the back of her head and made stars dance in her eyes. Cassiel was being as annoying as ever, but Crow couldn't take her eyes off the monster known as Soleil. She was dangerous. Too dangerous!

Crow swiped her talons at Soleil, but the construct bent her body unnaturally, evading the claws while snapping her leg up and kicking the bottom of Crow's beak. The impact slapped Crow's mouth closed and nearly caused her to bite off her own tongue!

"Caw-CAW!!!" Crow screeched, enraged. Her eyes smoldered with hatred unyielding.

Tiring of this attack from the front and back, Crow took a risk. She launched feathers from her backside at Cassiel, feathers made of iron as hard as demonstone, which

pursued her with a mind of their own. Cassiel yelped in surprise, diving to the side and flapping her wings hard to try and avoid the seemingly indestructible projectiles.

Soleil's attention was pulled away. She gave Crow a quick kick, then chased after Cassiel to try and knock the feather projectiles aside or take the blow for her master.

Crow's eyes flashed with insight. "Interesting..."

She realized that Soleil's devotion to Cassiel was more than that of a mere servant. It was is if she had been made specifically to protect the Lazarite's life.

How ludicrous! A Pureblood protecting a Lazarite? Even for the so-called Daughter of Heaven, wasn't this going too far? What was Raphael thinking when he assigned this strange angel to Cassiel's protective detail?

The details weren't too important. Crow gave chase, launching more of her feathers to chase after Cassiel in an attempt to hem her in and pin her down.

Unfortunately, while Crow's feathers were her deadliest long-ranged weapon, they were also her armor. Any feathers she launched might have slivers of their own will, but wherever they originated from on her body would inevitably become vulnerable to attack!

Just as Crow thought she'd uncovered a winning tactic to ensnare both angels, Soleil suddenly reversed course and flew right back at Crow, leaving Cassiel to fend for herself.

Crow's evil grin froze on her face.

She realized she'd been had!

Soleil saw through Crow's weakness as soon as she had launched her first feathery barrage. When she spun around, she used her smaller size and superior agility to dodge Crow's startled attack, then fly above Crow's back, where she spotted a small, exposed hole on Crow's back. The spot from where a few feathers had been launched!

BOOM!!!

Soleil's vicious punch plunged into Crow's back and tore into her spine, causing Crow to lose control of her body and plummet to the ground below. At the same time, Cassiel switched out her arsenal for a heavy set of divine armor. Crow's feathers bombarded her from multiple directions, but the armor held tight!

Crow smashed into the ground face-first. She quickly flipped onto her back, grinding her beak as she saw Soleil diving after her.

"Tricky little pigeon!!" Crow cursed.

Soleil slammed onto Crow's stomach, hammering her with the force of a freight train. Each punch and kick drove the wind from the demon's body. The Emperor of Sacrifice tried to swat Soleil off, but the construct's feet changed into claws that wrapped around Crow's feathers and held tight! When Crow finally managed to punch Soleil aside, she tore a few feathers out along with her.

Crow jumped to her feet and glowered at the construct while clutching her wounded stomach. She was bleeding from the front and back, and now that she had exposed her softer underbelly, she wasn't in as good of a fighting position as before.

Soleil back-flipped twice, then landed on her feet. She held up both fists, ready to counter whatever Crow brought to bear next.

But instead, a flash of evil went through Crow's eyes.

"It seems you like to play nasty! That's good. So do I!"

Crow closed her eyes and clapped her talons together. A beam of red light shot out of her body and raced into the sky, instantly vanishing from sight.

Unseen by Soleil, atop a volcano on the distant world of Diabolus, there sat a giant shrine in Crow's image. Hundreds of devoted and brainwashed acolytes dressed in the robes of various bird species cawed and cried out loud as the statue of their goddess began to light up the space with its glowing red eyes.

One of Crow's few remaining trusted Demon Dukes raised his wings.

"Our Emperor has entered battle! Begin the ritual!"

"Caw!"

"Caw-caw!!"

While the temple no longer had any humans inside it it due to Jason Hiro's influence a year earlier, it still had plenty of low to mid-ranking demons. They sent their demonic energy into the ritual, and their bodies either withered or inflated with power before exploding. One by one, each acolyte perished, giving their life force to their bird goddess.

Back on Sharmur, Crow's body doubled in density. She grew a meter taller, and regrew feathers to cover the parts that had lost their protection. She exhaled a turbid breath of blood-colored mist, then chuckled under her breath.

"Ugly little angel, this is the end. It was fun while it lasted."

Then she stormed toward Soleil.

The construct was ready. She leaped backward to evade Crow's talon swipe, then leaped forward with her fist raised to deliver a boulder-busting punch. When she struck Crow's face, Soleil's fist deformed. It was as if a toddler had struck the door to a bank vault! Her punch had no effect on Crow at all!

Soleil's pupils shrunk. She tried to jump away, but Crow moved more swiftly than before and reached out to grab her. She snatched the Black Hole Construct with a giant claw and wrapped all five talons around Soleil's waist.

"No escape this time!" Crow laughed.

Three bullets fired from behind struck the back of Crow's head. Cassiel had returned after pinning her feathers in place, but her attacks did nothing! She couldn't slow down Crow in the slightest!

Crow ignored Cassiel. One set of talons grabbed Soleil's legs, while the other grabbed her upper torso. Soleil did not scream, but her mouth opened in alarm as Crow began to pull!

RIIIIP!

Like pulling apart a stretchy piece of taffy, Crow turned Soleil's midsection into a long string of flesh colored gum. She was momentarily baffled before she realized the truth. Holding each of Soleil's wriggling halves in both hands, she gasped.

"So you weren't an angel after all! Lying bitch!! You were like Artoria! Another one of the Wordsmith's abominable creations! But too bad, you were too weak to defeat ME!"

Despite being ripped in half, Soleil was far from dead. Her body was made of hyper-dense black hole neutrinos. Thinking she had bested her foe, Crow's grip inadvertently relaxed, even if just a little. Soleil took that opportunity to grab Crow's thumb and wrench it with all her strength.

SNAP!

"Aaaargh!" Crow cried, as her thumb was brutally broken and dislocated. A spasm of pain went through her body, and she reflexively dropped Soleil's upper half.

Soleil struck the ground. Her upper torso morphed its shape, and she transformed into a half-sized version of herself, complete with arms and legs. At the same time, her lower half inside Crow's other hand turned liquid and malleable. She dripped through Crow's fingers and splashed to the ground, turning into another half-sized version of herself.

There were two versions of Soleil, both of them the size of a child. She might have looked adorable and huggable if she wasn't a living weapon capable of killing most demons below the rank of Emperor.

Crow snarled. She slapped her palm down to squash Soleil, but the child-sized constructs both grew pairs of wings and flew to the right and left before swooping around and kicking at Crow's head. At the same time, Cassiel realized Crow wasn't taking her existence seriously, which meant she had a real shot at hurting Crow if she could only just land one good hit.

Cassiel summoned an extra-long spear made of highly reinforced light magic. She de-summoned all her armor, knowing it put her in a more precarious position, but also that it was their best shot at slaying this giant. With Crow empowered by a Ritual, she was stronger than ever.

Soleil swooped around, drawing Crow's attention. Time and time again, she tried to kick and punch the giant brutish bird, but her attacks inflicted little damage. It seemed Crow had become damn near invincible after powering up. She swatted and slapped at the air, but she failed to hit the much-smaller Soleil duo.

Eventually, one of the Soleils rushed Crow from the back, and the other came at her from behind. Crow ended up grabbing at the one going for her stomach, but failed to notice the other one aiming for her back.

Instead of punching or kicking the Emperor, which had proven ineffective, the mini-Soleil wrapped her arms around three of Crow's feathers and yanked them out of her back.

Crow flinched. Having her feathers plucked wasn't exactly painful, but it wasn't pleasant either. She tried to grab at Soleil, but that particular spot on her back was one that Soleil had determined was not within her normal range of motion. Her wings hampered her hands' movements considerably!

"Gahh!! Get off me, you filthy false pigeon!" Crow roared.

Soleil jumped to the left, and Crow's eyes followed her. Crow did not notice Cassiel swooping down from above, her spear aiming for the exposed skin on Crow's back.

SHIK!

Cassiel impaled the spear an entire foot into Crow's back, sending pulses of divine energy deep into Crow's core. The Demon Emperor screamed in pain. She fell forward and collapsed to the ground, flailing behind herself to swat Cassiel off.

Even a light slap from Crow could shatter many of Cassiel's bones. Unlike Soleil, she was effectively as strong as an above-average human, albeit granted the power of wielding divine energy as a weapon. This meant her resistance to a raging Demon Emperor's attacks was basically nonexistent.

Thus, when Cassiel did not immediately jump off Crow's back, she showed great courage. She carefully and nimbly dodged Crow's flailing talons while wiggling the spear as much as possible to further widen the wound and cause as much damage as possible.

"Behind you!" Soleil cried.

Cassiel's heart nearly stopped. She flapped her wings and leaped skyward right as several of Crow's feathers from before flew at her. Crow nearly succeeded in impaling Cassiel, but ultimately failed.

With Cassiel gone, her spear of light dissipated, leaving a massive bloody hole in Crow's back. Crow coughed blood several times, then struggled to stand, carefully affixing her feathers back in place to hide her injury.

The truth was, Cassiel's sneak attack had done serious damage. Crow was not like Belial. She could not heal herself mid-battle, and thus injuries sustained had to be powered through.

Soleil's two halves combined back into one, and she stood tall once more. This time, Soleil used her strength to rip a rather large tree from the ground, then swing it down at Crow like a giant club!

Crow cawed with hatred. She punched upward at the falling tree and blasted it apart, then leaped skyward to grab at Soleil, who once again dodged.

"You cannot evade me forever! Caw-CAW!"

While Crow was injured badly and somewhat slowed, she didn't need to move too quickly to catch up to Soleil, as Soleil was still trying to land the killing blow.

Cassiel started to hesitate more and more. Crow might be injured, but she was still as dangerous as ever.

"We can't kill her... should we send an SOS to Melody? Where is she, anyway? Shouldn't she have come here by now?!"

Cassiel fired a blast of light into the sky that exploded like a firework! Unfortunately, in the midday sun, it wasn't very visible, but she hoped the spike of energy would at least draw someone's attention. She didn't dare leave Soleil alone with Crow, lest a tragedy unfold while she was gone.

It became obvious as the minutes ticked by that Crow's ritual was wearing off. Soleil began to pressure Crow. Her punches started inflicting serious damage once again.

Crow grimaced. She slapped and swiped at Soleil, but the damned false angel was too agile. For any attacks Crow landed, Soleil started landing two or even three hits, and those hits became progressively more punishing. It turned out that Crow's ritual had a major side effect. All of the wounds she suffered before and during the ritual, which had previously been suppressed, were now much more serious than ever. The gaping hole in her back had festered and become infected, leaving her coughing and sputtering in between blows suffered.

"Gahh!!" Crow cursed as she sloppily tried to cut Soleil in half with her claws. "Imposs-*COUGH*!! Impossible! I can't lose to a weak little rat like you!"

"Oh, but you can." Soleil said, dodging another swipe. "Just remember. It was the two of us working togeth- AH! Watch out!!"

Soleil suddenly snapped her attention to Cassiel, who was standing off to the side. Cassiel jerked in surprise, but she didn't see anything.

With Soleil momentarily distracted, Crow pounced. She didn't know what had distracted the false angel, but it was still a fortunate development for her. She successfully grabbed Soleil again, this time snatching her by the legs, lifting her overhead, then slamming her upper body into the ground with all her strength, over and over.

Soleil struggled to escape, but Crow didn't dare to let her go. Over and over, she beat Soleil against the ground, while Cassiel tried to distract her with attacks from the back, even taking back to the skies to attack Crow's injured back. Unfortunately, Crow's feathers kept the bloody hole covered, so Cassiel couldn't land a significant blow.

Again and again, Crow beat Soleil into the ground. She once more tore Soleil in half with frenzied rage, but this wasn't good enough for her. She started biting at each of Soleil's halves, ripping chunks of the construct out, then spitting those chunks on the ground and squashing them underfoot. Soleil could sustain her existence between a few different components and even recombine if introduced back together, but when the parts ripped out were small enough, they simply lost molecular cohesion and dissipated into mindless sludge.

Soleil weakly tried to punch Crow and wrench her thumb again, but Crow was fighting for her very life by this point. She knew Melody could arrive soon, and she knew that even if Melody didn't, her life was still in danger if Soleil escaped. This was her last shot at killing the construct. She had to make it count!!

Bit by bit, chunk by chunk, Crow ripped Soleil apart while Cassiel screamed and begged her to stop. Tears fell from Cassiel's eyes as she summoned a greathammer and uselessly slammed it against Crow's head from behind. This attack did some damage, but Crow still ignored it. Nothing was more important than eliminating the main threat!

And so she did. Eventually, both of Soleil's halves stopped struggling. They fell inert, then turned to mindless sludge in her claws.

Soleil, Cassiel's assigned protector, had died.

"NOOO!!" Cassiel shrieked, as she sensed that her closest friend had perished. She flew into a maddened rage and conjured her strongest armor, then started punching and kicking Crow as hard as she could. Each strike caused Cassiel's arms to ache and her skin to split. She went well beyond what her body could handle, ultimately hurting herself more than she hurt Crow. But the Demon Emperor relented.

After confirming she had successfully killed the false angel, Crow sneered. When Cassiel landed another punch, Crow abruptly spun and slashed with her talons, raking them across Cassiel's armored midsection and violently tearing through her defenses like they were paper. Four terrible slashes cut across Cassiel's stomach, and she fell backward, her armor dissipating.

She had nearly been disemboweled. Crow's single attack had left her bleeding profusely. If she did not receive medical attention, she might just die by the end of the day.

But that paled in comparison to the future awaiting her if Crow had her way. The Demon Emperor, now badly injured and limping in pain, still grinned victoriously, looking at her prey lying on her back.

"Hah... hahaha... this was ALL worth it!" Crow cackled. "I must thank you, little bitch. You really made me work for this. But that only makes the victory taste even sweeter!"

Crow loomed over Cassiel as the defeated Lazarite coughed and sputtered blood. She looked at Crow with eyes full of fear. She couldn't fight back anymore. Even the slightest movement would tear her stomach open. She was utterly at Crow's mercy.

"You... why are you doing this...?" Cassiel cried. "Your husband attacked me! I only defended myself! He-"

"SHUT UP!!!" Crow screeched. "You think a few cheap words will protect you?! It's the law of the jungle out here! Nobody's coming to save you! No knight in shining armor, no Melody, and certainly no Belial! Hehehehe, as we speak, all the demons are being convened to hear about the survival of a certain powerful ally of our people. Else, why do you think Melody wouldn't have shown by now? Because she isn't even on Sharmur! Hahaha!!"

Crow's voice softened. She leaned in close to Cassiel, then flashed a sadistic grin. "But don't worry, pretty girl. I'm not going to let you die here. I'm going to keep you alive for a long, long time! Locked in a dungeon, chained to a wall, made to be my funny little dancing monkey! I'll torture you, humiliate you, and treat you like my toy! You'll spend the rest of existence screaming, begging for freedom, begging me to kill you! And I'll only do so once all the fun is gone. But that will take a long, long time! Hahaha!"

Crow reached for Cassiel. Just as she was about to pick the angel up, Crow felt a presence to her left.

Her heart skipped a beat. *The false angel?!*

She quickly turned to face the newcomer, only to see someone she never expected in a million years.

A creature with two heads and four arms. Glowing eyes covered his body from chest to toe.

"Not a bad idea," Gressil, the Emperor of Chaos said. "But Crow, that privilege belongs to me. Not you."

Gressil's eyes burst with rage. He lunged at Crow and slammed his fist into her face, sending her sprawling! Crow crashed to the ground, then painfully staggered back to her feet, looking at him in disbelief.

"Gressil! You- what is the meaning of this?! We have no quarrel!"

"How dare you try to lay claim to *my* Birdie, you overgrown chicken." Gressil snarled. "She isn't *yours* to torture."

With a mighty roar, Gressil lunged at Crow. He began beating and wrestling the injured Demon Emperor, using his four limbs to overpower her, with his two upper limbs grabbing and controlling her head's range of motion while the lower two limbs either kept her arms at bay or slammed into her chest, over and over.

Cassiel watched with a blood-drained face as the one entity she hated and feared more than any other became her 'savior'. Gressil started beating the absolute shit out of Crow. Normally, he wouldn't stand a chance against her, but the combined damage she had taken from Soleil and Cassiel had weakened her enough that she was far from her prime fighting condition. She couldn't even activate a Ritual again, as the previous one had occurred too recently.

Crow began to panic. She tried mightily to break free from Gressil's arms, to escape his grasp, but she failed! At this point, she merely wanted to break free and escape with her life, but she realized, perhaps too late, that it was she who was at his mercy!

Thump! Thump! CRACK!

Gressil savagely beat and pulverized Crow. Even his face got in on the action as he occasionally bit at her feathers and yanked them out to spit them on the ground. Crow tried to summon her feathers to attack Gressil, but she realized she couldn't control them while Gressil was here. His Chaos Aura blocked all of her magical power!

"No! No! Nooo!!" Crow shrieked. Her cries became feeble and pitiful as Gressil grabbed her by the back of the neck and slammed her face-first into the dirt. Then he got on top of Crow and wrapped his two lower arms around her neck.

Crow's eyes bulged. Gressil was clearly trying to choke her to death! She grabbed at his lower arms to try and pull them off, but she failed to realize his two upper arms had grabbed hold of her beak...

With a violent wrenching twist, Gressil snapped Crow's neck. Her body ceased its resistance, and she fell silent.

Bit by bit, the light died in her eyes.

Her body went slack, but Gressil didn't end the fight there. He systematically began to shatter each of her limbs, break her bones, and render her completely unable to move. Her bent and mangled her body in increasingly horrifying ways, then waved his hand and caused her to disappear. Where he sent her, only he knew.

Then, Gressil turned to look at Cassiel. Her blood ran cold.

"Oh, Birdie. I've been trailing that evil chicken for quite a while." Gressil said with an almost loving smile, as if he were her knight in shining armor after all. He strode over to Cassiel, who shakily tried to push herself away with her feet. She didn't get far.

Tears welled up in Cassiel's eyes. She was all alone. Nobody was here but her and her worst enemy. She started to tremble violently, terrified of the fate she knew was about to befall her.

Gressil got down on one knee and lovingly stroked her face. Cassiel nearly vomited on the spot.

"Come now, Birdie. There's no need to be scared. Yes, I let that big bad chicken come here. I let her kill that ugly stain, Soleil. But that was just because your 'friend' was standing in the way of our joyful reunion. With Soleil gone, you and I can visit each other more often. Isn't that nice?"

Cassiel shivered. She couldn't speak. She could only clutch her injured stomach, wondering if it would be better to die right here and now, rather than end up back in Gressil's dungeon.

But contrary to her terror, Gressil did not abduct her. He simply looked her body up and down, his expression a mixture of lust and pity. "I'm sorry she hurt you like this. Don't worry. I'm not taking you back with me. I've actually grown to enjoy seeing you out in the wild, like this. Smiling, laughing, flourishing. I think it would be best if I allowed you to maintain your sense of independence."

He continued. "You were always so pretty, chained to my wall. But all the fight had gone out from your eyes, and along with it, a big part of what made you so... appetizing. How beautiful can a flower be if it never sees the sun or tastes the rain? So I'll make sure

you live free, and we get to spend time together once in a while. Without that eyesore in both our ways, we can see each other whenever we want. Won't that be nice?"

"G-get... get away... from me..." Cassiel whimpered.

"Oh, I know you don't mean that." Gressil said, his smile making her want to crawl into a hole and die. "Since I can't have you succumbing to your injuries... consider this a final parting gift."

Gressil reached down and touched Cassiel's Heavenly Shroud, returning her to her human form. Then he waved his hand. The scenery abruptly changed around Cassiel. Gressil vanished, and she found herself inside the new hospital located in Eastern Melodia.

As soon as she arrived, a familiar Harpie, Doctor Fathy, who was in charge of the hospital when Belial wasn't around, gasped when Cassiel appeared practically right in front of her. "What? Who are you? Where did you come from?!"

Fathy stared at Cassiel with deep shock for a moment before shaking her head. Then she called for help, and various medical assistants ran into the room.

Belial and Leeroy were both gone, but luckily, the facilities on Melodia weren't bad. Cassiel was put onto a gurney, her angelic form obscured by the Heaven's Shroud. As she was rushed into the emergency room, Cassiel's heart palpitated with fear.

She couldn't see or sense Gressil anymore. He must still be there... watching her... from the shadows.

But Soleil wasn't here to protect Cassiel anymore. She felt naked and exposed... exactly the way Gressil wanted her to feel.

The doctors put a mask on her face, one which pumped a strange gas into her lungs. Cassiel's eyes became weak and started to flutter shut.

As the sedatives took her to a dreamland, Cassiel wept. She wept over the death of her friend, and she wept over what Soleil's disappearance meant for her future.

She was alone again.

Part 699: Humanity's Backup Plan

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. 4PM. Eastern Melodia.

Inside the unified headquarters of Melodia's Defenders, Belial finally finished explaining the situation to a small group of people. Among them were Commander Linda Adams, Commander Chadwick, Melody, Beelzebub, and Kiari. They were all sitting inside Linda's office, which felt a bit cramped with so many people stuffed inside, but nobody complained.

"That's the long and short of it." Belial concluded. "As we speak, the other demons are spreading the word of Raphael and Uzziel's deception. We don't know how long we have until the Kolvaxians attack. We don't know *if* they will attack. But since the charade is up and their plan has been revealed early, I don't imagine it'll be long."

The others remained silent for a time. Beelzebub was the first to speak.

"I'm not so certain." Beelzebub said.

"About what?" Linda asked.

He pondered for a moment.

"About whether or not the angels will actually attack. Think about it. Even if the Psions hadn't completely imploded due to Demila's betrayal, do you really believe the entirety of the Psion Army could withstand a regenerating enemy force led by a competent, perfectly intelligent leader like Uzziel? If she wanted to overwhelm the galaxy, she would have done so already."

He continued. "This isn't about winning. It's about *revenge*. Uzziel feels slighted. She wants to inflict pain and suffering on us, to make us feel small, weak, and snuff out our hope. I'm not sure she's actually going to start rapidly overtaking worlds now that the jig is up. I think she's going to continue slowly swallowing the galaxy, laughing at us because she thinks it's delightful that we're pissing our pants in terror or trying to mount a pointless, feckless resistance."

"That's a nice sentiment, I guess." Linda said calmly. "But you're merely guessing. What makes you even think your assumption has any merit?"

Beelzebub shrugged sheepishly. "Well... because not long ago, I also was a rather vindictive bastard who wanted revenge. It just seems in character for her... and me. The old me, I mean. Not that I'm not *still* a vindictive bastard, but I digress..."

Linda sighed and looked off to the side, rubbing her head. "Yes, I suppose you have a point."

Chadwick cleared his throat. "Ahem. Let us not dwell on hypothetical scenarios and mental states of our enemy. We need to think about concrete actions we can take."

He waited until he had everyone's attention before continuing.

"Unifying every species to battle the Kolvaxians is not only our best chance at winning, but is in fact our only chance. These monsters are so durable that even our heaviest artillery cannons will barely stagger them for a moment. We have weapons that might be capable of stalling them out, such as the Stasis Grenades we used to great effect on Maiura, but those can only buy us a little time."

"So what do you propose?" Linda asked.

"The Cube." Chadwick said. "The Phoenix is a Middle Cosmic now, yes? It is not powerful enough to protect us from the Archangels-"

"She isn't a combatant at all." Beelzebub interrupted. "The Phoenix is only capable of creating worlds and controlling the cube. If even a Low Cosmic breaches the interior, she won't be able to- well, actually, she does have the Sentry Stars... I don't know how powerful they are though."

"Yes yes, but let me finish my point." Chadwick said while waving his hand. "Isn't there a colossal amount of space inside the Cube? A truly unfathomable amount beyond the size of multiple solar systems?"

Beelzebub blinked. "Yes... why? Surely you're not thinking..."

"That Cube is not only vast, with ample room for growth, but it is hidden, mobile, and it can sustain life." Chadwick said slowly. "Don't you see? We've treated it as a throwaway training depot, or a backup option for far too long. I believe we must relocate key worlds inside the Cube before the Plague can infest them!"

The entire room went quiet. Belial silently gasped.

"That... that could work!" Belial said. "Beelzebub, is it possible? Can the Phoenix put a few stars inside the Cube and create self-sustaining planetary orbits? Can she create an

entire ecosystem of worlds for us to live upon?"

Beelzebub rubbed his chin. He fell into thought.

"...Give me a moment."

He closed his eyes and folded his hands in his lap. Then he bowed his head. Belial was surprised when she felt his demonic aura abruptly disappear, as if his soul had left his body.

Chadwick opened his mouth to speak, but Linda held a finger up to her lips. He opted to remain silent.

A minute later, Beelzebub's aura returned. He chewed his lower lip, then nodded his head.

"The Phoenix has spoken. We can indeed do this. She can transport entire worlds inside the Cube. The cost is high, but not extreme. And the more worlds rich in life that we bring, the more energy she can use to bring in additional ones. But, it's not all roses and daffodils."

Beelzebub waggled a finger in warning. "The Phoenix says that she can only put worlds inside the Cube by moving the Cube near them. This means that she can only do so once the Cube is inside a star system."

Linda frowned. "The Cube needs to warp across the galaxy. It requires time to move around."

"That's right." Beelzebub said. "If Uzziel catches on, she could completely destroy all our efforts by infesting a world before we take it into the Cube, then unleashing the Plague when we least expect it, collapsing our resistance immediately. In the worst case scenario, we have to assume we will only be able to bring one star system's worth of planets with us. After all, the Cube was created by Camael, not Raphael, and he is unlikely to know it possesses this function. But after we do it once, he may discover our deception and take steps to prevent us from doing so in the future."

The entire room fell silent.

All at once, everyone realized this solution was not as simple as it sounded.

"How do we decide which world to save?" Kiari asked quietly, her heart heavy with emotions due to her husband's funeral, but her mind steeled with determination for their

child. "I like Sharmur, but it has a small population. Volgarius is the densest world in the galaxy. If we're going by the number of lives we could save..."

"What about the Demon Deities?" Melody asked, also speaking for the first time. "My power is bound to the energy of not only Sharmur's star, but all its planets as well. Is it possible that by moving an entire star system into the Cube, I could retain my power? Then we would have a Middle Cosmic inside, able to assist the Phoenix and provide a powerful defense."

"If so, then that would mean we could protect the other Demon Deities." Beelzebub pointed out. "Right now, we can evacuate all the mortal demons into the Labyrinth. It should be hardened against a Kolvaxian invasion by virtue of existing in a protected dimension, especially after Diablo altered its core functions and gave it new power. But if we do that, the Demon Deities bound to planets and stars will be left naked and vulnerable. Alone, they have no chance against one of the Archangels, let alone a Kolvaxian horde."

"We can't leave them to die." Melody said, nodding. "They are all powerhouses whose abilities we could come to rely on. Especially Auger and Yardrat, but I wouldn't discount Vespera or any of the others. A Cosmic is a Cosmic, after all."

Chadwick looked uneasy. "Sharing a galaxy with these Deities is one thing, but packing all of us into the Cube with them? Melody, you can provide us some assurance of protection because if any of them get any ideas, they can only attack us one at a time. But if they're all in the Cube together, we'll be at their mercy! You cannot possibly beat back ten Middle Cosmics at once!"

Melody grimaced. "No shit, I can't. But the situation is bad. We have to act quickly before Uzziel and Raphael catch wind of our plans! Galactic unification is our only prayer for victory."

The other leaders looked uneasy. After all, in the best case scenario, they would be shoving many core worlds together comprised of species that hated each other just a couple of weeks prior, and one of those species even committed a genocide.

None of the humans wanted to ally with or trust the Volgrim, but they had no choice. The Volgrim were countless epochs more advanced than humanity. If the humans and the demons holed up alone, the humans might be able to hide from the Plague long enough to

build up their own form of space forces, but they didn't know how long they would be able to hide from the Archangels. Every second counted in a war of this scale.

"We must consider another angle." Linda pointed out. "Raw resources. These planets are more than just habitable surfaces for us to live upon. They also contain raw resources we can harvest to make weapons, armor, and ships for our future counter-attack against the Kolvaxians."

"A good point." Beelzebub said. "I will tell the Phoenix to travel to Sharmur post-haste, but also to search for lifeless systems along the way we might be able to sneakily add to the Cube. Even if they cannot harbor life now, the Phoenix might be able to change that, and we should at least be able to use these lumps of rock and ice for raw materials."

The other leaders nodded. They started quickly hashing out the details of this plan, but in the middle of the meeting, someone pounded on the office door. Linda let them in, and it turned out to be her assistant, Debra.

"There's been an incident!" Debra exclaimed. "Cassiel was attacked, and Soleil is missing! Cassiel is in the hospital with severe injuries."

"What! Who would dare?!" Melody asked.

"Everyone, I have to go. I'll return when I can!" Belial exclaimed.

As she got up, Melody joined her. The two of them left the room together, leaving the others to sit in stunned silence.

"Cassiel...?" Beelzebub asked.

"The angel girl. The one Jason rescued from the Labyrinth." Chadwick answered. "You weren't there for that operation, but it was an important day where we also recovered Hope Hiro from Gressil."

"Oh. I think someone did mention that before..." Beelzebub said, scratching his head. "Wait, so that means we have another angel in our midst?"

"We sure do. And she's not just *any* angel..." Linda said, before quietly explaining the full extent of the matter to Beelzebub.

* * *

Belial rushed to the hospital while trying not to panic. In her head, she felt that the timing of this attack was way too coincidental. How did the attacker know Belial wasn't at

Cassiel's side? Was it Gressil? Was Soleil not strong enough to protect her after all?

Melody sped things up by flying at Cosmic speeds, arriving at the hospital with Belial in tow in less than ten seconds. If she wasn't worried about accidentally killing people, she could have arrived nearly instantly, but a lot of people from many different species lived in the hospital's region. Better to be safe than sorry.

Not long afterward, the two demons stepped into Cassiel's hospital room, where several doctors were standing with their hands on their hips, clearly at a loss.

"Samantha!" Doctor Fathy said, relieved to see her. "You arrived quickly. That's good. Chirrup! The patient is hiding in the corner over there. We think she's suffering a mental break right now, and we don't have the ability to restrain her."

She pointed to a corner of the room, tucked behind the hospital bed. Belial craned her neck and spotted Cassiel rocking back and forth in a corner, her pupils shrunken to pinpricks, her teeth chattering as she pressed her body against the wall. She sat in the fetal position, looking around the room in terror.

"He's here... he's here... he's watching... he's watching... don't let him come near... no, no, no don't let him come near..." Cassiel whispered under her breath. Her eyes moved at lightning speeds, looking from left to right and back to the left again. Her eyes were moving so frantically that she couldn't properly see or register the world around her.

"We tried to sedate her," Fathy explained. "But she woke up and startled us. Her biology makes her resistant to drugs meant for humans-"

"It's fine. I'm here now." Belial said. "Let me try talking to her..."

Melody stayed at the doorway. She towered over the human and monster doctors and nurses looking pensively at the angel-in-human-form. It seemed the Heaven's Shroud had continued to hide her form, even though the people present knew who she was.

Belial carefully walked over to the edge of the bed. Cassiel didn't even seem to register her presence. She instead continued to look in every direction, as if searching for ghosts... or worse.

"Cass? Cassiel?" Belial whispered. "Can you hear me? I'm going to come a little closer..."

Cassiel's teeth chattered violently. She closed her eyes and grabbed the sides of her head. "He's watching... he's here... he's watching he's here he's watching he's here... oh

god oh god..."

A shiver went down Belial's spine. It didn't take a genius to figure out who Cassiel was talking about. There was only one creature that would leave her in a state like this.

Belial crouched down and moved closer. She carefully reached out and stopped just short of touching Cassiel's shoulder.

"Cass, Cass I'm here now. Are you-"

Cassiel's eyes snapped open. She suddenly realized Belial was there, and she lunged forward, wrapping her arms around Belial, shaking and trembling with incomprehensible terror. She buried her head in Belial's chest and shook like a leaf.

"He planned this- he killed her. Killed her. Killed her. She's dead. Oh god, I shouldn't- I was too weak... too weak, he killed her..."

Belial hugged Cassiel tightly. She looked around the room and tilted her head at the others.

"Everyone but Melody, leave us please."

The others nodded. They quietly left, while Melody stood guard at the door.

Belial carefully mouthed a word at her without speaking.

"*Gressil*."

Melody's eyebrows twitched. She scanned the room with her Cosmic senses, but she didn't see anyone...

"He's... he's not here..." Belial said to Cassiel, whispering softly. "Cass, it's alright now. I'm here. I'm sorry I left you behind. I'll never do that again, okay?"

Cassiel nodded vigorously, but it was clear that she had completely collapsed back into her own world. Her panic was so palpable that it put Belial and Melody both on edge.

Cassiel carefully opened her eyes. She pulled her face away from Belial's chest, then looked up into her eyes. Her teeth were clenched so hard that her chattering had begun to transmit to the rest of her body, making her shiver and tremble even harder than before.

Slowly, she peeped to the right. She spotted Melody and seemed to look at her for an instant... then Cassiel's skin lost all its color. Her eyes moved, ever so slightly, to Melody's right.

She screamed.

"Eeeyyaahh!!!"

Cassiel dove for the corner again and covered her head with her arms.

"HE'S HERE!! HE'S HERE!! MAKE HIM LEAVE! NO, NO, NO, MAKE HIM GO MAKE HIM LEAVE MAKE HIM GO!!"

Belial's gaze whipped around the room. She spent two full seconds searching for Gressil's presence, but she didn't see him anywhere. She had no idea what Cassiel had seen, or if she had seen anything at all!

"He's not here!" Belial exclaimed, quickly getting in front of Cassiel and covering the angel's body with her own. "Cass, Cass! Calm down, there's nobody here! He's not-"

"I SEE HIM! HE'S RIGHT THEEERE!" Cassiel cried, tears pouring like a fountain. "Oh god, he's going to hurt me! He's going to take me again and hurt me and torture me I DON'T WANT TO GO!!"

Melody also scanned the room. She kept her Cosmic senses alert, but if Gressil was in the room, she could not detect him at all. She genuinely could not tell if Cassiel was hallucinating because of trauma, or if she saw an illusion of Gressil, or if he suddenly appeared for a split second when Melody and Belial's attention was focused on Cassiel. Come to think of it, Melody had never actually sensed Gressil since becoming a Demon Deity, so she didn't know if his ability to hide was stronger than her ability to sense life forms.

Was such a thing even possible? Could a Demon Emperor really possess an ability stronger than a Middle Cosmic? The very notion sounded absurd.

Belial helplessly could do nothing more than shield Cassiel's body with her own. Cassiel sobbed and cried uncontrollably. She was completely hysterical.

And so, like that, Belial only barely managed to draw out the story of what had happened over the course of an entire hour. In between cries of terror, Cassiel torturously managed to let out a little of what had happened, bit by bit, until Belial and Melody had pieced the whole story together.

Melody looked out the window. She fell into thought, her face turning into a pastiche of anger, with a feeling of betrayal running beneath the surface.

So Crow came here and attacked Cassiel because Cassiel was the one who killed Emperor Red Raven during the Energy Wars. That follows. But how did Crow learn of

Cassiel's identity? It seems Vespera must have identified her! To think this is how the demons would act while speaking of 'unification' and other such glorious terms.

She turned to Belial. "I need to speak to Auger. Will you be able to stay here with her?"

Belial nodded. "With Soleil gone, Cass is completely vulnerable. I'll stay by her side 24/7 until we can find a way to keep her safe."

"Alright." Melody said, nodding her head ever so slightly. "I will return."

Melody exited the hospital room. After she departed, Belial looked around, searching for the invisible bastard who was likely skulking in the corners of her vision. A chill went down Belial's back. She had always felt assured that the combined strength of herself and Soleil would easily beat Gressil to a pulp, but she wasn't 100% certain she could defeat him alone, especially if she needed to protect Cassiel at the same time.

Worse, she now knew that Gressil could teleport himself and other entities. His powers were somewhat diverse, but also highly specialized. He could nullify her healing magic, he was strong enough to stand up to her if a fistfight broke out, he had the mobility advantage, and he could even deceive her senses with illusions.

If Gressil ever became serious about capturing Cassiel, Belial doubted she could truly stop him.

He was *toying* with the angel. Otherwise, why transport her to the hospital? He could have captured her right after killing Soleil! That meant he was either completely assured of nabbing her in the future, or he derived some sort of sick *pleasure* from her suffering.

What a bastard, Belial thought.

"Cass, you need to come with me to a safer location." Belial whispered. "The Hospital isn't secure."

"Secure??" Cassiel hissed under her breath, her heart racing. "Nowhere's secure! Don't you see?! He can be anywhere! He's here right now! Right now!! How can I go on like this?! No, god, Sam... just kill me now! Kill me and end my suffering! Please!!"

Belial's eyes hardened. "Don't talk like that. You are the last true angel. Your existence is special. If you give up now, what will Soleil's sacrifice have been for?! We need to train you to become even stronger, strong to the point that that evil bastard won't ever dare to come near you again! Strong enough that you can hunt him down, make him fear ever having crossed your path!"

Belial's powerful speech did nothing to help Cassiel's mood. In her eyes, Belial was simply naive and foolish, not comprehending the power of Cassiel's tormentor.

Become stronger than Gressil? How could that be possible. Even Melody couldn't sense that he was right there, in the room.

As Belial helped Cassiel shakily stand up, Cassiel's blood ran cold.

Gressil stood, not even three feet away, right behind Belial's back. He grinned at Cassiel, then slowly held a finger up to his mouth.

"*Shhh*..."

Belial never sensed a thing. She was completely clueless.

Cassiel's mind could no longer handle the trauma. She fainted from fear yet again, and the last thing she heard was Belial's cries of alarm as the ground rushed to meet her falling form...

Part 700: Unarin's Obstinance

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Noon, Volgarius.

By all accounts, Unarin was not having a good day. Or a good week, or a good month, or frankly not even a particularly good decade.

Things were not going his way. The Volgrim had all but lost their right to call themselves the galaxy's ruler. With the reveal of the Apex Cosmic known as Dolgris, it did at least seem that a chance to defeat the Plague, albeit at a high personal cost, had landed in Unarin's lap.

Naturally, Unarin was fine with not being the strongest entity in his Empire. He previously had employed Dosena as his primary enforcer, so nominally keeping his title as First Founder while 'somewhat' answering to Dolgris was just fine by him. If anything, it was a big upgrade, since Dolgris appeared to be far stronger than Dosena.

But then Auger showed up, and the news he brought was just about as bad, if not worse, than much of the already bad news Unarin had heard many times of late.

"...So, that is essentially the situation." Auger concluded, his Astral Body seated in a chair before a small round table within Unarin's Sanctum. "We are not fighting a crudely intelligent super bio-mass, but an army controlled and coordinated by Archangels Uzziel and Raphael. It is also possible the remaining Archangels may join them, perhaps willingly, or perhaps unwillingly. I daresay this changes everything."

Unarin sat on the opposite side of the table. His expression was completely neutral. He appeared as unbothered as if Auger had just told him there was a chance of rain later in the afternoon.

Unarin lifted a tasteful golden glass to his lips, one made by goblin artisans that featured a skull motif of some animal from their homeworld. He took a strangely long, silent sip of a rare wine from some unknown world while looking off into the distance.

"Hmm." Unarin grunted.

Auger stared at him for a few moments.

"*Hmm?* Is that all you have to say?" Auger asked. "I do not wish to press you, but time is of the essence, Unarin. We need to come up with a counter-measure for the Plague."

Unarin took another long sip of wine. He set the cup down and exhaled quietly.

"You've made one minor error in your judgment, Auger." Unarin said.

When several seconds of silence passed but Unarin didn't elaborate, Auger blinked three times. He was secretly stunned by Unarin's seeming disinterest in this new revelation.

"Then please advise me." Auger said, feeling resentful at the way Unarin was blatantly dragging out his words. "What error?"

Unarin chuckled. "This changes nothing. Not for me or the Volgrim, anyway. I already hypothesized that the Plague was being controlled by a central entity a long time ago. The thought the angels might be involved even crossed my mind, but I only thought there was a small chance of that being true. It seems even I didn't give Raphael enough credit. The old bat's schemes run deep."

"I see. But how does this 'not change anything'?" Auger asked. "It seems to me that we're about to imminently experience a complete collapse! We have to move quickly and find an exit strategy before the Kolvaxians move en-masse!"

Unarin leaned back in his chair. He sighed and looked up at the ceiling, admiring the detailed and intricate murals that had been hand-drawn by some of the finest creatures from across the galaxy. He always enjoyed looking up at them, scrutinizing their intricate linework and the depictions of various fantastical battles of fictitious and historical renown.

"Oh, Auger..." Unarin said softly. "When I say that I have long anticipated a revelation such as this, I mean that I have already factored it into my contingency plans. You may think the Volgrim Empire is helpless without our Psions, and the destruction across Volgarius certainly seems extreme, but in truth I long ago factored in the possibility of a complete collapse among the Psionic ranks. The fact Dosena still lives and will recover her power bodes well for us, and we still have a small handful of elites, such as Confessor Vulpanix."

"In truth," Unarin continued, "the current situation is better than I anticipated. Our enemy is an angel, a veritable past ally of humankind. She is vicious and unscrupulous. She is intelligent and driven by motivations of the personal kind. At the same time, her brother aims to become this galaxy's Ruler. In my eyes, he is not my enemy. I am quite

fine with taking orders from Ruler Raphael. Where there is intelligence among my enemies, there is room to barter."

Auger stared at Unarin as if he were an idiot.

"Barter? What need has he to barter with the likes of you? If Uzziel infests the bodies of your people, she will gain all their knowledge and abilities! She can simply take what she wants by force!"

Unarin snapped his eyes downward to meet Auger's gaze.

"*Oh really? Can she?*"

Auger's words caught in his throat. He, a legendary Middle Cosmic, revered among the demons and considered a wise sage by many of his people, became dumbstruck when Unarin suddenly gave that that strange, knowing look.

"Y-yes..." Auger said hesitantly. "That's... that is the point of all this. She is taking our bodies and using them for her own gain... just look at your infested Executors!"

Unarin lifted his body up and leaned forward, resting his elbows on the table. He gave Auger a knowing smile.

"If that is the case, dear Auger, then where are the ships?"

Auger became truly tongue-tied.

"The... the ships...?" He asked, uncomprehendingly.

"Yes. The ships. The spaceships. Void-traversing weapons of war based on Volgrim design." Unarin said in a tone that was somewhat mocking of his much more powerful peer across the table. "If Uzziel can take control of all the knowledge within the heads of my people, then why hasn't she built an armada capable of traveling the stars, crushing us all under the guns of Armageddon, and rendering us too fearful to fight back? Don't tell me you haven't thought of this matter."

Auger snapped back to attention. "You assume she doesn't have them! She could be hiding millions of them across the worlds long-ago-lost to the Plague, waiting for this day to arrive!

Unarin smiled smugly. He shook his head.

"She's not. Of that, I'm certain. Either Uzziel does not wish to build ships because of some foolish aversion to technology, or she simply cannot. The first indicates another

personality flaw I *could* use to my advantage. The second represents a core failing I will *absolutely* use to my advantage."

"You don't know that! You're guessing!" Auger shouted.

"Oh, but I do know it for a fact." Unarin immediately countered. "She has not built one ship across all of the worlds the Plague has taken. I can promise you this with 100% certainty."

"That's impossible. There's no way you could know." Auger repeated, more firmly than before.

Unarin shrugged. He leaned back in his chair and fanned out his finger to examine his nails.

"I have my sources. Believe what you will."

Auger scoffed. He couldn't believe what he was hearing. "You're willing to bet the future of the Volgrim, the Demons, and the Humans, as well as all the other Sentients of our galaxy, on this hunch? Even if you truly are correct, so what? Her Kolvaxians all possess the powers of Psions! They can fly through the Void unobstructed. They have bodies harder than the armor on most of your ships. They possess awe-inspiring telekinetic powers that can rip through any defense. She doesn't NEED to build machines of war!"

"Ah, you forgot a few." Unarin said casually. "She also has the powers of various Demon Emperors at her command, along with whatever abilities the angels and Archangels possess. You're not giving her enough credit."

Auger wanted to rip his hair out. "Confound you, Unarin! Even if all of that is correct… so what?! Do you really think your measly forces can offer her something she cares about? Do you think you can bedevil this monstress with that silver tongue of yours?!"

"Why not?" Unarin asked. "It seems to have worked on you."

Silence fell.

Auger stared at Unarin, his mouth half-agape. He realized he'd been verbally bested, and the damnedest thing was, he wasn't entirely certain where he went wrong!

"Do you… truly think… you can bargain your way out of this?" Auger finally asked. "Become the lapdog of some creature hellbent on devouring the galaxy?"

"Perhaps." Unarin conceded, sagging into his chair. "And if that fails, I still have a few fallback options remaining. My contingencies are not entirely used up."

A light dinged on the wall, and a soft alarm tone played once. Unarin glanced at it.

"Oh. It seems Demon Deity Melody has arrived." Unarin said. "Come in, then. Have some wine, if you like."

A phantasmal entity phased through the wall and arrived inside Unarin's Sanctum. Demon Deity Melody glowered at Auger, giving him an ugly expression filled with hate.

"Auger! You have some explaining to do!" Melody barked. "How dare you send Crow to my world to cause mayhem!"

"Crow?" Auger asked, stupefied by her unexpected verbal assault. He expected her to come here and speak of unification with Unarin, maybe change the First Founder's mind. Instead she was... throwing around strange accusations??

"What a good look of innocence!" Melody shouted, her very voice turning into a sonic attack that struck Auger's body and made his phantasmal form waver slightly. "She attacked two of the people on my world and murdered one of them! Don't tell me you don't know about this!"

Auger glanced at Unarin, then returned to his gaze to Melody. It was obvious he was completely bewildered.

Auger slowly stood up, but his body wasn't as tall or as muscular as Melody's. She was an absolutely massive woman, towering a full head over most. With his hunched posture, Auger seemed shorter than he really was, which didn't help the matter.

"Melody, there seems to have been a misunderstanding." Auger said carefully. "I swear in the name of the ancient demons that I have no knowledge of what you're talking about. Can you explain the matter to me in more detail? I promise you I would not risk a war between the demons and humans, especially after Barbatos's revelations! It doesn't benefit me at all."

"Would it benefit you if the one Crow came to kill was... the *last living angel*, hidden among my people?" Melody snarled.

"What? An angel?" Auger asked.

Even Unarin's eyes flickered with interest. A thought came to his mind regarding a soul stolen by Hope, the fragmented soul of Archangel Uzziel. It occurred to him now that

this second soul might be living among the humans, somehow mixing in with them and secretly living an 'ordinary' life.

Could she, perhaps, be weaponized against her other self? It was a thought worth considering. But Unarin did not speak of this out loud.

"That's right. An angel!" Melody said with more righteous vigor than ever. Her aura flared to life, and her eyes lit up with power as she looked down upon the old man before her. While Auger was not exactly cowering, and he was definitely much more powerful than he seemed, it was clear that he was trying to defuse the situation rather than inflame tensions further.

"Again, Melody, I have no awareness of what you speak." Auger said. "If you would be so kind as to humor me, give me more details, I would be greatly appreciative."

In the face of Auger's relentlessly kind and servile tone, some of Melody's rage deflated. It was hard to maintain aggression in the face of calmness, so she reduced her rage to an angry glower.

"You really don't know?" Melody asked.

"I do not." Auger affirmed.

"For what it's worth, I believe Auger." Unarin chimed in. "And you should know... I'm *quite* good at reading people."

Melody glanced at Unarin. Her expression turned to a frown. Unarin was well-known for his ability to see through other Sentients, so she found his words believable.

"Fine! I'll explain it then!" Melody snapped, returning her attention to Auger. "A short while ago, Belial was taken to heal Barbatos. At some point, Vespera must have noticed the Heaven's Shroud concealing the angel on Sharmur, and that information was relayed to Crow, who has a long-held vendetta against this particular angel."

Auger blinked. "May I ask... who? What angel are you referring to?"

Melody hesitated. Now that it had come to this, if she didn't tell Auger the name, he would surely find out anyway. She didn't want to expose Cassiel's identity, but it seemed the time for secrecy was over.

"...We call her Cassiel." Melody said. "But you might better know her as... the Daughter of Heaven! The strongest Lazarite."

Unarin blinked. For once, he was completely surprised. He had assumed she was Uzziel, reborn through Hope Hiro's magic, but it seemed that wasn't the case.

Then, with no other choice, Melody summarized how they found Cassiel trapped inside Gressil's chambers, tortured and beaten, and had concealed her existence for years.

"Heaven's Daughter." Auger said, stroking his long white beard contemplatively. "I see. She was the one who killed Red Raven. It's only natural Crow would want to murder her. Where is Crow now? I can deliver her to you to punish her as you see fit."

Melody looked at Auger blankly. "You don't even know that much? Crow is dead. Gressil killed her!"

"WHAT?!" Auger roared, his eyes widening in shock. "Gressil did?! But he's... how strong has he become?! This is- this is simply unthinkable! I can't believe he has the guts to kill one of my minions! No, never mind that... Crow was a powerful asset to the Seven Hells. But the fact she went incommunicado like that and attacked Sharmur without my knowledge is a stain that could have ended our future alliance."

Auger quickly bent his head into a bow. "Melody, I am truly sorry for what has transpired. I did not order Crow to act, and I had no knowledge it had happened. Even if I knew the last Lazarite was with you, do you really think I would be so stupid as to endanger our friendship over one mortal angel? She is not a Cosmic, and is of no threat to me."

Melody's eyes hardened again. "You really didn't order the attack? You swear on your life? Because I am going to investigate this matter, and if I find any discrepancies, I'll rip your fucking head off!"

"I swear on the name of Satan himself." Auger said, slapping his heart loudly. "Vespera certainly has something to do with this. You should speak to her next, and I will not inform her you are coming, nor will I communicate with her in any way until you've had your say."

Melody nodded.

"Fine!"

With that, the matter was defused. Unfortunately, Soleil was dead, but so was Crow, and both sides had tragically lost a powerful champion. It seemed unlikely Melody would

be able to find anyone else to punish, aside from perhaps Vespera. She would definitely have words for her later, of course.

A few minutes passed. After cooling off, Melody and Auger walked over to sit at the table with Unarin. He smiled politely at the powerful demoness.

"Wine?"

"No thanks." Melody said blandly. "My Astral Body can't exactly drink it anyway."

"Ah. A shame." Unarin said, taking a swig of it immediately after. "I'll drink extra for both of you."

Melody glanced at him, then looked at Auger.

"Actually! I didn't only come here to possibly kick Auger's ass. As it just so happens, we might have a solution to the Plague problem."

Melody waved her hand and conjured a powerful barrier around the table in the hopes of eliminating any eavesdroppers. She already knew of the existence of the Spynet Sphere, but she didn't know if Raphael or others had set up something similar elsewhere.

Then, she explained the new Cube Plan to Auger and Unarin both. This was extra convenient because they were the leaders of their respective species.

Auger's eyes lit up. "Truly? You can preserve the power of Demon Deities by placing their star systems inside the Cube? This is a most fortuitous revelation! If you can do that, we can use the Cube's time dilation to quickly build up an army and use the Volgrim's technology to create war vessels to fight the Plague. Perhaps we might even uncover a method to Ascend further and create High or Apex Cosmics!"

Unarin was not as easily impressed. "Once you start teleporting worlds inside the Cube, it won't take long for Uzziel, or more likely Raphael, to notice what you've done. The disappearance of a solar mass is quite noticeable to high level Cosmics, as their power is subtly linked to the state of their home galaxy. Even more so for a super-organism like Uzziel, whose Plague has infested so many worlds around the Milky Way."

"We know." Melody said. "We've already considered this. In the worst case scenario, we may only be able to steal a single solar system before Uzziel goes on the offensive, infesting worlds before we arrive. We'd be placing planets inside the Cube, pre-infested, allowing a future catastrophe to emerge. As such, we're thinking of only placing one star system inside."

She paused.

"As much as I would like to preserve my life and power, Sharmur may not be the ideal system. Unarin, we were thinking of putting the Volgrim home system inside the Cube."

Unarin looked at Melody. His gaze did not hold any particular interest or excitement.

"The Volgarian System?" Unarin asked. "Let me guess. Because of our powerful military might, our advanced technology, and other similar concerns?"

"Every planet in this system is highly developed, heavily populated, and worth preserving." Melody explained. "If we're going by the goal of saving as many lives as possible, your system is the obvious candidate. This, in spite of *what you did* to Tarus II."

She glared evenly at Unarin. In that moment, her rage was even greater than what she had shown Auger earlier. It suddenly became tempting for her to reach over and slap Unarin to death. With one quick movement, she would instantly repay the Volgrim for all the humans they had killed! The Empire would likely collapse afterward, but that was a small price to pay for-

"Don't bother." Unarin said, interrupting Melody's thoughts. "Just preserve Sharmur and some other planets if you like. The Volgarian Home System will be fine as it is now."

Melody blinked. She looked at Unarin as if he were stupid. "What? You're saying... *no*? Just like that? You're not even going to mull it over??"

Unarin shrugged. "We'll be fine. If anything, this new revelation about Uzziel and Raphael has been some of the better news I've heard in a while. If we were facing some malevolent super-organism hivemind, I'd be a lot more worried. But an intelligent Archangel? One with thoughts and desires I might be able to exploit? I will be content to take my chances with her."

Melody looked dumbfounded. She genuinely could not believe Unarin would give up a shot at safety and refuge in order to flip a coin by battling his enemy's psyche.

Was he prideful? Arrogant? Stupid?

Maybe he was simply built different.

Melody shook her head with disapproval, but she didn't press the matter. "Unarin, if you will not take the precaution of moving your worlds to safety, may I suggest an alternative? Send humanity as many Technopaths as you can spare. We need to educate the humans and get them up to speed on your shipbuilding practices. If you won't do this

to ensure the survival of your people, at least do it to uplift others and create an additional backup plan."

Auger nodded. "A sensible choice. I don't believe technology will be of much use against the Plagueborn, but every additional brick we can lay to build a stronger future is worth pursuing."

Unarin mulled this idea over.

"Well, assuming that I make headway and convince Uzziel to let the Volgrim Empire serve as her vassal, sending you all those Technopaths would make it seem as if I'm planning to betray her."

"That's assuming she discovers this backup ploy." Auger pointed out. "You don't have to send the Technopaths now, out in the open. You could... dispatch a few smaller vessels. Put a few of your mid-grade Technopaths on board, along with a bunch of lower grade ones. It won't be as effective as nabbing a Celestial Designer to assist the humans, but the benefit will still be quite decent, and will be a lot easier to explain as a ship 'going missing in the Void'. The devils know there are Great Void Beasts out there, devouring anything they can wrap their tentacles around."

Unarin smiled faintly. "Yes, I suppose that is a bit more palatable. I'll have Randis carefully dig up some names. But do be warned; I may not even send them to you unless the talks go poorly with the Archangels."

"In the meantime, we have these 'Cybernites' that have been helping us out." Melody said. "I don't know all the details, but they seem to be rather smart."

"Oh yes, Marie Becker's creations." Unarin said, his smile turning mysterious. "Those entities are certainly more than they seem. Frankly, with them on your side, I hardly think my Technopaths will amount to much. But then again, Marie Becker is lacking when it comes to shipbuilding and military doctrines. She's much better at creating weapons of war. My Technopaths might be able to shore up the spots her drones are not as talented in."

The three leaders spent another hour hashing out all the details. Eventually, Auger took his leave, followed by Melody. They bowed their heads and departed, leaving Unarin behind.

The First Founder tapped his finger on the table.

He stared ahead at nothing in particular, thinking a million thoughts a minute.

"Is it finally time?" He wondered quietly. "Time to unleash… the Blinding Light Protocol? Let's hope it doesn't come to that. I only have enough energy to do it once… I had *better* make it count."

Part 701: "Too Easy"

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Weeks passed inside Aevum. These amounted to less than an hour in the outside world. All the while, Jason continued to work with Daisy's friends, improving the understanding of their abilities.

Outside, the slow march of the demons toward Mount Sinai continued. For every second that passed in Realspace, the demons drew closer and closer to beginning their assault on Sinai. The good news was, they needed time to move their troops into position and put down infernal formations capable of obscuring their numbers and army compositions.

Jason still had time to stop the war before too many died. But he wasn't bothered. Even if a million angels and a million demons died before he finally took action, it was a small price to pay. He was looking at the bigger picture.

Right now, Jason likened himself to the earlygame phase of an RTS. He had a choice. He could either quickly build up an army and begin his offensive, or play the economy game and build himself up for a stronger endgame. The choice was obvious.

No matter how brutal the war seemed to be, it wasn't at the level of existential doom and would need a long time to reach such a state. As long as the Volgrim were out there, Jason would not risk revealing his true capabilities early just to save a few million lives.

As such, it was a random Tuesday inside Aevum when Jason stood up from his seated lotus position, stretched his legs, and cracked his back. He smiled at the four spiritual incarnations surrounding him.

"Finally done." Jason said to nobody in particular.

Jason vanished from the spot. He reappeared inside a house built inside Aevum's designated residential area to the east, not far from the central Nexus Spire. Jason looked around, then frowned when he saw his father laying on a couch, a bowl of popcorn on his belly, his head turned to the side while a TV played an episode of some sitcom.

"BAHAHAHAHA!!" Hideki laughed, his roar making Jason raise an eyebrow. "Ahahaha!! Holy shit, Joey is the best!"

Jason cleared his throat. "Uh, dad-"

"Yeah yeah, I know. You're doing that MindCore operation on the angel hottie, yadda yadda." Hideki said, waving his hand to shoo his son away. "I'm sure it'll go fine. Now leave me alone, I'm watching Friends."

Jason took a few steps into the room and glanced at the TV. "Haven't you already seen every program to ever exist?"

"Nope. I didn't spend much time watching TV or movies or playing games." Hideki said. "I decided to catch up now! Don't worry, I'm sure you've got everything under control."

Jason scowled at Hideki. "Dad, come on. For the last week, you've just been sitting around, watching TV while I do all the prep work for important stuff. And when you're not watching TV, you're chasing Ose around like a lost puppy. Can't you do something useful for once?"

Hideki glared at Jason. "Kid, don't go smart-mouthing your old man. I've got things under control. I can just rewind whenever I watch an episode and start the next one. Relax, it's no big deal."

"Yeah? Then why have you been watching for a week straight?" Jason asked.

"Because it's annoying to rewind and eat the same bowl of popcorn eighty times!" Hideki fired back. "So I'll rewind ONE time and move on to the next show instead. Now fuck off and let me watch my TV in peace."

Jason sighed. His dad felt off from his usual self, but Jason didn't know why.

"Why are you suddenly being so lazy?" Jason asked, more insistently than before. "Look, dad, we still have a war to win. I can probably do it myself, but it would be helpful if you could contribute in some way. Why not help me train the new kids and Daisy, or put your future knowledge to use by passing it on to Nadia-"

Before Jason could finish his sentence, Hideki suddenly slapped the bowl of popcorn off his belly and leaped to his feet. His eyes smoldered with rage.

"Listen here, you little shithead!" Hideki shouted. "I'm not doing anything because it's not *fun* to do anything anymore! There's no challenge! You've made everything too easy for me! So I just sit here and watch TV because at least I find it somewhat entertaining. Got it?!"

"The fuck are you talking about?" Jason asked. "Too easy? What's too easy??"

Hideki dramatically rolled his eyes.

"You want to see? Fine. I'll show you. *But only this once*. Make sure you keep your eyes on me while I move around. You won't want to miss a second."

Hideki snapped his fingers. He abruptly vanished, startling Jason. After a moment, Jason also teleported away, returning to the Spynet v2, where he looked at a microscopic spy drone he had implanted into his father's right eye. Nominally, Hideki didn't know about it, but Jason assumed he did and simply didn't feel the need to say anything.

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Hideki instantly arrived inside one of Jason's supposedly secret warehouses in Aevum, where he grabbed a T-REX Harness Jason had recreated. He wrapped the harness wires around his arms and clicked the lock into place behind his back, then he put a shirt on over it, activated the nanites, and armored up his body.

Nanites flooded Hideki's body, eventually covering him from head to toe. Weirdly, Hideki then grabbed his nekomimi mask and put that on over top of the faceless helmet.

Hideki teleported into the armory inside his house, where he found his rifle sitting on the wall, along with a new .44 Magnum Jason had recently made. It was, obviously, enhanced with magical principles to grant it a massively empowered damage capability, along with reductions to its kick so it wouldn't fly out of his hand when he fired it.

Hideki didn't even look at the rifle. He grabbed the magnum, then held it in his right hand with casual contempt.

After finishing his basic prep work, Hideki vanished again.

He reappeared inside Russia, right inside the office of Russia's sovereign leader. Before Vladimir had a chance to react, Cat Mask had already pulled the trigger at point-blank range, executing the man and blasting his skull into fragments, along with shattering the entire wall behind him.

Jason gasped. He didn't expect his father to move with such brutal intent!

Then Cat Mask disappeared again. He started teleporting behind several top leaders of the Kremlin, taking them out.

After wiping out Russia's entire top brass in under five minutes, Cat Mask arrived in North Korea. Their dictators fell in an equally short time.

Several cartels around the world perished over the coming minutes. Jason gazed with horror at the situation. Cat Mask was unstoppable when it came to defeating these weak, mortal humans. They were little more than sacks of meat that posed him no threat.

Then, Cat Mask switched targets. He reappeared in the vicinity of Mount Sinai, an arm's length behind Satan the Devil.

Satan instantly detected the arrival of someone behind him. He turned to look at who would dare to intrude on his presence, only for a bullet to fire into his brain and instantly kill him.

Jason stared. Killing Satan was easy, but his regeneration...

Hideki's next move completely floored Jason. He grabbed Satan's body before its headless form could even fall to the ground. Then he vanished again.

Cat Mask teleported somewhere Jason didn't immediately recognize. It was pitch black, with specks of light that barely stood out in the blackness. Then Jason saw Hideki turn to look at an ungodly massive, unthinkably huge stellar object.

It was Sol, earth's sun!

Still holding Satan's dead corpse, Hideki suddenly teleported forward three times in a row, somehow abusing the physics of the teleportations to momentarily accelerate his body to extreme speeds. He hurled Satan at the sun, then teleported away.

With Hideki gone, Jason couldn't see what happened to him, but he realized in an instant.

"Of course! If Satan can regenerate instantly, then throwing him into a star will burn him up endlessly before he can regenerate!! Why did I never think of this?!"

Jason used his Wordsmithing to look for Satan's corpse. He found it right before it fell into the sun's corona and became swallowed by the fires of a yellow star.

But Hideki didn't stop there. He popped Diablo in the head, then he teleported him into the sun too.

Lucifer came next. Then Auger...

Hideki didn't bother with any other demons beyond that. Either they were too tough for this trick to keep working, or he got bored of doing it.

It turned out that just throwing Demon Emperors into a goddamn star was a functional way of instantly killing them! What a stupid but effective strategy!

Hideki paused for a moment. He seemed to sigh about something as he looked at Mount Sinai, then he shook his head.

Jason wasn't sure what that meant. Was he implying he could kill Raphael with a similar tactic? Or was Raphael immune? Maybe Hideki just didn't want to bother with the trouble??

Hideki vanished. He didn't travel to Heaven. Instead, he suddenly appeared somewhere Jason didn't recognize at all.

It was some sort of alien... shrine? There were skulls of countless exobeasts on the wall, each of them completely unique from the ones around them. They were massive skulls, weighing tens or even hundreds of kilograms, and sometimes as big as a car!

The purple colored walls were roughly hewn and crystalline, glowing with alien energy.

Jason couldn't tell where this place was, but he figured it out when he spotted a figure seated in a lotus position less than twenty meters away from where Hideki had arrived. She was meditating atop a raised platform, and abruptly lifted her head when Hideki intruded on her Sanctum.

[Who are you?] Founder Dosena asked, her many eyes narrowing to glare daggers at the armored figure that had appeared inside her secret dimension. [I do not recognize your species.]

"Sup." Hideki said, before lifting his magnum and aiming at her head. "I'm a human."

BLAM.

The bullet fired from his magnum with enough force to punch through a bank vault. It struck an energy barrier surrounding the Second Founder and ricocheted off, then struck one of the walls before ricocheting three more times.

Eventually the room became quiet again.

Hideki stood as still as a statue, his gun continuing to aim at Dosena's head.

"That... was supposed to work." Hideki said, after ten long seconds.

[Unfortunately for you...] Dosena said, her eyes narrowing to slits, [...it did not.]

She levitated to her feet in an instant, then reached out her hand to grab hold of Hideki. She seized his body with the power of a Middle Cosmic, while Jason watched in horror.

The Wordsmith didn't know what to do! He had just seen his father execute a bunch of extremely powerful enemies in a row. Surely, he would have had a plan for arriving here! Was there a way Jason could save him?!

[It was brave of you to come here alone.] Dosena said, her voice booming with power. [Foolish, but admirable. How did you uncover the location of my Sanctum and break through its temporal defenses? As a mortal, this should not be possible.]

Hideki groaned with pain as Dosena's telekinetic energy started to bend his limbs in directions they were not supposed to bend.

"Aaaugh! I'll... I'll never... tell a fat... ugly bitch... like you!!"

The insult slid right off Dosena's back. Coming from an ant, it meant nothing to her.

[Suit yourself.] Dosena said. [In that case, I will simply obtain the answers by force.]

She reached out her other hand and sent a telepathic beam of energy firing into Hideki's head. At once, she began looking through his memories, all tens of billions of years worth of them.

A guttural scream of incomprehensibility suddenly erupted in the air as Hideki deliberately lowered his mental defenses. He greedily allowed the Second Founder to probe his mind and sent the full accumulation of information firing right back into her brain.

[AAAAARGH!!!] Dosena shrieked, as her Psionic Seed fell into chaos. She unwittingly released Hideki, then fell to her knees, grabbing the sides of her head while swaying from side to side.

At that moment, every drop of psionic energy in the air vanished. So much information had flooded into her brain that only a mental master dedicated to sorting through such vast quantities of information, specifically Solomon, could have dealt with it.

Hideki grunted. He landed in his feet, but swayed a little himself. Dosena's psionic grip had hurt him noticeably, but luckily she was taking it easy on him.

"Fucking bitch." Hideki spat, before lifting his magnum once again.

BLAM!

This time, the bullet obliterated her brain, sprayed skull fragments in a cone behind her, and left Dosena's lifeless corpse to keel over and flop to the ground.

Her suffering was over. She had been killed by a mere mortal.

Hideki rubbed his neck and scowled. "God, that hurt like hell. What a cunt. She just *had* to wrench me around, huh?"

He sighed again. Then he vanished from the spot.

All the while, Jason gaped like an idiot at the monitor displaying the feat his father had just accomplished. He had already thought executing multiple Demon Emperors and most of Earth's despots in minutes was a feat beyond comprehension... but killing a Middle Cosmic? How was that even possible?!

The next thing Jason saw when his father reappeared was the back of a familiar head.

Unarin, seated inside his Sanctum, stirred when he sensed a presence materialize behind himself.

He turned around to see an armored bipedal soldier wearing a strange mask on top of his helmet. The soldier was armed with a small handheld weapon of some sort, but he wasn't pointing it at Unarin.

Unarin stood up and turned to face the intruder.

For thirty long seconds, the two of them simply stood and stared at once another.

"...So it was you." Unarin said, his expression emotionless. "You killed Dosena."

Naturally, Unarin had sensed her presence disappear. He had known Dosena for so long that her aura was utterly unmistakable. When it disappeared, that usually signified that she had left Volgarius. But since she would usually inform Unarin of her coming and going, and since this strange soldier had just appeared, it was easy to put two and two together.

"You're dangerous." Hideki said. "Of the many entities living in this galaxy, you're one of the precious few I have the least confidence in killing."

Unarin linked his hands behind his back. He tilted his chin up to look down the bridge of his nose at Cat Mask.

"I am unarmed and defenseless. What are you implying? That I have some way to take down someone who has killed my most powerful defender? If you have killed Dosena, then it is clear I am about to die."

Hideki snorted.

"Unlikely."

The two men once again fell into silence.

After a few long moments, Hideki shrugged.

"It doesn't matter. I've made my point."

"And what point would that be?" Unarin asked.

But Cat Mask did not answer. He simply vanished from sight, and Unarin raised an eyebrow.

"...What an interesting creature."

He didn't seem to care at all that Dosena had been murdered, removing the Volgrim's mightiest defender from the equation.

It was as if her life never truly mattered to him.

* * *

Hideki reappeared inside his room back in Aevum. Jason materialized in front of him only two seconds later, as Hideki started pulling off his nekomimi mask.

"Dad! Holy shit!" Jason exclaimed. "You just... what did you even do?! You've neutered the Volgrim and made them way less threatening, plus you took out the demon leadership... have you been able to do that this whole time?!"

Hideki deactivated the T-REX, and after it was gone, he flopped on the couch and groaned in pain.

"Yeah... since you gave me all these abilities, anyway. You really don't understand just what a Rewinder can do with teleportation alone, kid. Though I will admit the other abilities and enhanced weapons help a lot."

Jason felt the blood drain from his face. "You're like... like a one-man army! I still can't believe it! I think I'm in shock!"

"Yeah, yeah. Mind handing me an ice-pack or something?" Hideki grunted. "My... *everything*... is killing me."

Jason slapped his own forehead. "**Heal!** There, feeling better?"

"Yeah. Wow, sometimes I forget you can do stuff like that." Hideki said with a chuckle. His body felt as good as new.

A short silence followed.

"So... what do we do now?" Jason asked. "You've completely changed the course of the coming war."

"I don't know. Don't really care, either." Hideki said, choosing to lay back on the couch. "It's all too easy now. If I had these abilities the first time around, you wouldn't have even needed to go in the cryopod in the first place. Just leave me alone and let me watch my TV now."

Jason nodded. He smiled at his father. "Yeah, sure thing, dad. It seems I still have a long way to go as a Hero. You've truly opened my eyes today."

Jason sighed one last time, then he vanished.

A few minutes later, he reappeared, a look of deep concern on his face.

"Uh... dad?"

"Yes?" Hideki asked.

"It's... Diablo." Jason said quietly. "He just transformed into the Archdemon. Killing him in the sun only made him assume his ultimate form. Also, Satan regenerated enough times to break free of the sun. They're both... coming back to Earth."

Father and son looked at each other.

"...I didn't know Diablo could do that." Hideki said. "The fuck is an 'Archdemon'?"

"A really powerful Cosmic form that can flatten planets, regenerate from nearly any injury, and is as big as a skyscraper." Jason replied.

"Oh." Hideki grunted.

Another minute passed.

"So... what are we gonna do?" Jason asked.

Hideki dramatically rolled his eyes. "For fuck's sake. There's always *something*. You know what? Killing Lucifer was a bad idea anyway, because then it'd just piss Ose off and make it harder for me to woo her. You're on your own, kid."

"On my own?" Jason asked.

But before he could get a response, his dad's body blurred, and time began to rewind...

Jason threw his arms up in the air and scowled at his father.

"Why are you suddenly being so lazy?" Jason asked, more insistently than before. "Look, dad, we still have a war to win. I can probably do it myself, but it would be helpful if you could contribute in some way. Why not help me train the new kids and Daisy, or put your future knowledge to use by passing it on to Nadia-"

Before Jason could finish his sentence, Hideki suddenly slapped the bowl of popcorn off his belly and leaped to his feet. His eyes smoldered with rage.

"Listen here, you little shithead!" Hideki shouted. "I'm not doing anything because it's not *fun* to do anything anymore! There's no challenge! You've made everything too easy for me! So I just sit here and watch TV because at least I find it somewhat entertaining. Got it?!"

"The fuck are you talking about?" Jason asked. "Too easy? What's too easy??"

Hideki paused. He breathed in and out a few times, glaring daggers at his son.

Then, his body blurred.

All the anger on his face abruptly disappeared. He shrugged at Jason.

"Eh. You wouldn't get it even if I told you."

Hideki looked around the room at his spilled popcorn. Great, now he'd have to cook some more.

He grabbed the bowl and wandered into the kitchen while Jason followed him, steam metaphorically coming out of his ears.

"Dad! What does that MEAN?!"

"You'll figure out your own solution eventually." Hideki said, as he prepared to cook himself more popcorn. "Now piss off, will ya? I wanna watch my sitcoms."

Jason groaned. "FINE! Be lazy, then. I'm off to operate on Catherine."

"Sure, sure." Hideki said. He didn't even turn to look when Jason disappeared.

A few minutes later, Hideki plunked back on the couch with a new bowl of popcorn. He completely ignored the rest of the popcorn he'd thrown all over the floor earlier.

"Ahahaha! I fucking love you, Chandler!"

Part 702: Mentally Corrupted MindCore

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Inside a specially created operation chamber deep within Aevum's confines, Catherine D'arc sat in a comfortable chair beside the operating table. She stared at Jason expectantly as he manipulated a magical holographic interface. Dozens of tiny little dots were placed all over Catherine's face and head. These dots were magical nodes used to read and scan her brain activity in real-time, and Jason used them to carefully integrate his newest v3 Mindcore into the simulated representation of Catherine's Mind Realm.

After several hours of preparation, Jason was finally done. Catherine looked at the holographic brain floating in midair, but she couldn't perceive anything about it that was different from any other brain. She wasn't a brain surgeon and had little knowledge of how they worked. In her eyes, a brain was a brain.

As for a Mind Realm, she was only slightly less ignorant. Raphael had taught her how to manifest blueprints and diagrams inside hers and then take them out in the middle of combat to swiftly summon armor and other things, but she only knew how to follow his directions and improve its functions a little bit over a long period of time. She was far from an expert.

"The prep work is done." Jason said, wiping sweat from his forehead. He gave Catherine a solemn look. "Are you sure you want to do this? Remember that you're the first person who I've ever operated on. I don't know if the Mindcore will kill you, or if it will be successful. I'm 90% confident the outcome will be extremely positive, but there's a one in ten chance things might go poorly. So… are you sure?"

Catherine was surprisingly calm, despite the fact she was about to put her life in the hands of a stranger. She'd spent a few weeks inside Aevum, getting to know Jason, but all she truly had to go off was her gut instinct about him. She didn't sense any hostility, only hesitation and worry. It was clear Jason was afraid of what he might do to her.

He cared. He had lost someone important to himself in the past, and that colored his view of the world.

Catherine knew that feeling well. She had also lost someone precious to her.

"I trust you." Catherine said quietly, meeting his gaze with her own.

Her eyes were soft and warm. She seemed not to suspect his motives at all, as if she were a naive child. But the truth was, she had already thought of the consequences and made her decision days ago. Short of a sudden look of malice or evil cackling erupting from Jason's mouth, she believed he was a good person who would do his best to improve her capabilities.

And if she died? That was okay. He had already told her the war was originally lost. Her death wouldn't make a material difference.

She was somewhat daring, in that regard. She liked to take big bets with her own life. Perhaps if she had been born and raised in the modern era, she might have grown up to be a daredevil stunt biker or a high stakes poker player.

Who could say?

"Alright. Ah, so if you take a seat on the operating chair, I'll get to work. Um, I think I should restrain you, just in case. But if you're not comfortable with that... I guess I can try to work around it." Jason said.

Jason couldn't help himself. The 'Cassiel' he knew was a victim of Gressil's torture and rape and other godawful acts for 100,000 years. *That* Cassiel would be horrified or go insane if he mentioned restraints. Even suggesting such a thing made him feel a little ill.

But the woman in front of him now was not 'Cassiel'. She was Catherine, a warrior who had never known fear. She was extremely brave, and as such, she only thought the hitch in his throat when he said 'restraint' was simply a bit of awkwardness.

"That's fine. I don't want to lash out by accident. It could affect the surgery, and also... I simply don't want to hurt you." Catherine said.

Jason smiled, but he still felt awkward. When Catherine climbed into the medical chair, he restrained her wrists and ankles with Wordsmithium, but made sure not to tighten the restraints too much. She could still slip out if she tried.

"Don't forget my wings." Catherine pointed out. "You'd be surprised how much damage they can do."

"Oh. yeah, of course." Jason said, laughing in a weird tone.

He thus restrained her wings, then wrapped a band around her forehead, locking her in place.

After a moment, the two of them fell silent, with Catherine looking up at Doctor Jason with a slight smile on her face.

"What is it?" Jason asked. "Is something funny?"

"Oh, no, not exactly. It's just… you look like a kid who got caught with his hand in the cookie jar." Catherine laughed. "Plus, you keep giving me these strange looks."

Jason hesitated. He looked off to the side and rubbed his arm.

"You… you sort of resemble my wife. Phoebe. She had white hair like you. But she… she died. And, I feel that it was my fault."

Catherine remained silent. This prompted Jason to add more details.

"I don't really know what killed her. It happened in the future I came from. But I still feel it was somehow… my fault. So, I'm worried I'll… I'll screw up again. And hurt you like I hurt her."

Jason rubbed his hands together apprehensively as he met Catherine's gaze.

"I don't think I could live with myself if that happened." He concluded.

"Well, you'd better do a good job, then." Catherine said. "I'm counting on you."

"Right." Jason muttered.

The Wordsmith inhaled, then exhaled. While this operation was going, he had returned all his Dronesmiths to Aevum and reintegrated their soul splinters back into his own soul, since he would want 100% of his mental focus. He had informed Daisy, and she decided not to tell her friends.

The time was ripe.

After steadying himself for a short minute, Jason uttered his first Word of Power.

"**Focus.**"

Immediately, his mind sharpened. All other tasks vanished from thought. He stopped thinking about the demons, the Volgrim, his worries about the past, or even the existence of his father and daughter.

Only Catherine's life mattered. He had to do right by her.

Jason walked behind Catherine's operation chair and leaned forward, his head hovering upside-down above hers. He pressed one palm on each side of her head, covering her ears. Patterns behind to emerge in his mind's eye.

"**Transpose. Sublimate. Review.**"

Jason peered into the depths of Catherine's Mind Realm. What he found was a somewhat barren wasteland made of clouds. Scattered around this cloudy world, there were hundreds of small crystals levitating a few feet off the ground, each one containing a blueprint Catherine had made over the years.

"**Gather. Store.**"

Jason collected these blueprints, taking them from Catherine's Mind Realm into his own. At this point, he had stolen all her life's work. If her left her like this, he would have robbed her of hundreds of years worth of hard work!

But of course, he would return these memory fragments later. The first thing he had to do was remake her Mind Realm anew.

"**Purge.**"

With one Word of Power, Jason send a powerful wave of magic across Catherine's Mind Realm, obliterating the heavenly clouds that composited her soul's powers. Catherine flinched on the chair and gasped, letting out a squeak of pain as the horrible torment ripped a part of herself away.

"I'm sorry." Jason said, his voice somewhat monotone. "Please bear with it. It only gets worse from here."

Jason bit his lower lip. He had no choice but to persevere now.

"**Scour.**" Jason said, sending another wave of magic to rip across Catherine's Mind Realm.

Her entire body jolted as he tore up even the small remaining fragments of her Mind Realm, breaking down the 'bedrock' of who she was. Catherine's eyes watered, and she let out a yelp of pain. It was fortunate that Jason had bound her forehead in place, or she might have jumped out of his grasp involuntarily.

Jason hesitated. He knew this was going to hurt, but it seemed like her tolerance for pain was far lower than his. Was it because she hadn't experienced the kind of pain he had?

For a brief instant, Jason remembered what he had gone through in his hundreds of years of life. He had once used a Word of Power to accelerate his body, only to crash against a wall and nearly kill himself on the spot.

He had been left paralyzed by the Black Witch, his throat cut, a feeling of hopelessness draped over his inner self.

He had suffered multiple agonizing defeats to various demons, and the emotional pain inflicted when his daughter and wife died was just as torturous.

But, in kind, those bouts of suffering had hardened his resolve and made it so he was able to push through Mildred's surgery! Pain was always awful to experience, and trauma was not something anyone wished to suffer from, but what did not kill a man tended to make him stronger.

Perhaps Catherine had not endured such torment. If this were the Cassiel of the future, he had no doubt she would prove much hardier...

"Go on..." Catherine coughed. "I'm fine. I am... fine..."

Her eyes teared up from the pain, but Catherine steeled her resolve. She sensed that Jason had stopped because of her screams, but she didn't even mean to do such a thing. They were completely involuntary.

Jason continued to hesitate. He looked at Catherine and felt a mixture of pity and worry.

This was only the initial stages of the surgery. The next ones were going to be far, far more agonizing...

But then, a lightbulb seemed to pop up over Jason's head.

"**Examine.**" Jason said.

He quickly focused on Catherine's cerebral composition. He focused on the part of her brain that processed pain...

"**Reroute.**"

He completely shifted the pathways so that instead of pain, all those electrical signals would, at least temporarily, alter course and travel to her pleasure centers.

"I'm going to continue." Jason said. "This next part... might be a little weird. I apologize in advance if it doesn't work."

He swallowed heavily. Then he spoke a Word of Power.

"**Reform.**"

At once, a rocky ground emerged inside Catherine's mind, a planet-shaped asteroid that began growing to the size of a moon, and then a planet.

Catherine yelped again, but this time, her tone was one of confusion. She had tensed up, expecting another burst of agony, but instead, her body heated up, and endorphins started to flood her thoughts.

"Ahh! Nnn, ahh..."

She made a series of very strange noises that, frankly, made Jason feel equally strange. They were... *erotic*, to say the least.

Jason blinked. He looked down at Catherine's face, and she was blushing so hard that her entire face had turned pink.

"Sorry!" Jason said. "Just bear with it. **Enrich!**"

The rocky world Jason had made suddenly changed composition. Leylines similar to those used on Aevum sprouted from a designated point and rapidly wrapped around the planet, causing Catherine's magical energy to spread throughout it. Jason had hardly done anything, and already he had boosted the raw and unrefined 'power' of Catherine's Mind Realm twofold. If he stopped the operation right here, she would surely be able to think twice as fast as before, especially when it came to harnessing her magical powers.

He had no intention of stopping early, though. This was only the beginning.

Jason began speaking more and more Words of Power. Catherine's cries became more and more intense as he summoned Titan-like architecture inside her Mind Realm, summoning mountains, palaces, and other giant living spaces that each housed unique artifacts he had made earlier that week.

Catherine pressed her knees together. Her wrists struggled within the restraints, and she felt she was going absolutely mad with lust. The operation had become unbearably pleasurous, to the point she felt like a feral cat in heat. The worst part was, she was completely aware of her surroundings, and she knew these feelings were fake, but she couldn't control herself at all.

Those feelings were nominally better than suffering the raw agony from before, but they were excruciating in their own way too!

"Ahh! Nnngh, aaiieh!" Catherine cried.

"We've barely even started! You have to hold on!" Jason said.

* * *

Ten minutes passed. An hour.

Five hours later, Catherine was sobbing uncontrollably from the pleasure. It felt like she had been locked inside a star, its heat burning her clothes and skin and muscles and bones, but with lust instead of pain. She felt that if the ugliest man in the world presented himself, she could jump his bones for the next year straight. Electrical pulses surged through her body, making her chest rise and fall as she swallowed stuttering breaths and her eyes spun in circles.

As for Jason, the operation was going better than he expected. Catherine was in no danger of dying, but her erotic moans were definitely doing something weird to him as well. He continually had to remind himself that she was not his wife and he had no interest, but he really couldn't help feeling maybe he had a *little* interest.

Only to then metaphorically slap himself silly. She was his patient, nothing more.

After those five long hours had passed, Jason finally finished his work. He summoned a crystal in the void above the world he had crafted inside Catherine's Mind Realm. This crystal performed a great many functions, but the most important one was allowing her to create duplicate holo-worlds inside of her Mind Realm, each one using quantum mechanics to somehow exist inside a separate dimensional space without requiring any extra room!

Jason blinked his eyes. His body felt heavy from exhaustion, as he had completely drained himself during these last few hours.

Catherine wasn't much better off. Her entire body had completely soaked her clothes with sweat. Her angelic robes had turned nearly transparent, giving Jason an eyeful of sights he really couldn't afford to see right now.

And so, after stabilizing her RealitySim v3, Jason staggered backward a few steps and slumped against the wall. He breathed raggedly, while allowing Catherine to slowly regulate her breathing again. With the operation over, Catherine was finally able to begin a slow return to sanity, though her mind was filled with all kinds of lurid, regretful, extremely embarrassing thoughts.

She had always been raised to see herself as a Lazarite above the common rabble. Her heart had never belonged to anyone. But now she wasn't sure what she felt. It seemed as if the operation had turned her into a harlot consumed by desire. She felt ashamed, even despite knowing these feelings were forced and unnatural.

As Catherine laid on her back, breathing heavily and perspiring, her clothes stuck to her body as if there were tree sap slathered between the two. She wiggled around a little, but couldn't escape the restraints. When Jason walked over, she blushed madly, suddenly feeling she was in a vulnerable position. It seemed to her as if he was about to reach out and grope her while she was helpless.

Jason stopped. He looked at her, then coughed.

"Are you... feeling okay?"

"I'm f-fine..." Catherine said, shuddering under his gaze. "If the operation is done... p-please release me now."

"Of course." Jason whispered.

He waved his hand. "**Remove.**"

The shackles binding her to the operation chair vanished. Catherine quickly sat up and covered her chest with her hands, but then a bout of wooziness struck her. She nearly fell off the opposite side of the chair and had to seize hold of its arms to steady herself.

Jason stepped forward and grabbed her shoulder. "Easy there. Don't fall. Are you really okay?"

She shuddered at his touch. The procedure was over, but all those strange feelings continued to linger. She pulled away, then climbed off the opposite side of the chair to get away from him and swayed on her feet when she stood.

With a bit of distance between herself and Jason, Catherine suddenly felt something was different about her eyes. Or perhaps it wasn't her eyes, but her brain. Her Mind Realm.

The way she looked at the world had shifted drastically. She could see lines of energy passing around the walls. The Leylines Jason had fed into the room to speed up the operation had been hidden from her before, but with her Mind Realm attuned to Titan architecture, anything comprised of such principles were laid bare before her.

Jason remained silent. He watched as Catherine's eyes darted around. The color of her skin had mostly returned to normal, and it was obvious at a glance that she was now finally experiencing the wonders of her MindCore. He even felt a little jealous, because his was only a v1, but hers was a v3.

v3 was much more compact, energy efficient, effective at its functionality, and easier to install then the previous iterations. Even if he hadn't turned her pain to pleasure, it was much less likely she would die on the operating chair than when he nearly did. But still, he didn't regret what he had done.

Hopefully, she wouldn't resent him for it...

"Catherine." Jason said.

She flinched, not expecting him to speak. Catherine returned to reality and looked at Jason like a deer frozen in the headlights.

"I need to switch your brain back to... to switch it from pleasure back to pain." Jason explained lamely. "It doesn't have to be right now. Just at some point before you leave."

"Is... is that why I felt... so strange during the operation?" Catherine whispered.

"Yes. Sorry I didn't explain it before." Jason said. "I just figured it would be better than experiencing the agony of having your soul ripped apart and stitched together again."

He paused.

"Do you want any food? Water? Anything like that?"

Catherine looked down at her body. She blushed.

"A shower... would be nice."

"Right!" Jason exclaimed. "I could use my magic to clean you up. It would only take a secon-"

"No, no, thank you!" Catherine quickly interrupted. "A shower. Please."

Jason swallowed the other words he was planning to say. It was clear to him that she had been thoroughly embarrassed and didn't quite feel comfortable in his presence anymore.

"Give me a minute. I'll create one over there." Jason said, gesturing to the wall behind her.

He did a bit of Wordsmithing and summoned a private bathroom for her, even conjuring various perfumes, shampoos, towels, and other essentials from a random grocery store on Earth. He created a duplicate of her clothes, nice and clean, then left them in the bathroom.

"Have at it." Jason said, before turning to walk away.

"Wait!" Catherine said, causing Jason to pause.

He turned to look at her.

"Yes?" Jason asked, raising an eyebrow.

"Um." Catherine grunted. "I'm sorry. I must seem ungrateful to you. But I'm not. I'm... extremely happy. This new MindCore is... it's incredible. I just, I don't know how to feel right now, and my head is all mixed up, and..."

She trailed off, uncertain what to add.

"I get it." Jason said with a smile. "You're welcome. If you want, I can erase your memory of the procedure. Maybe then things won't feel so awkward between us."

Catherine accidentally giggled, revealing a pure and beautiful smile different from before. "No, no, that won't be necessary. A little awkwardness isn't exactly... *bad*. Is it?"

"By no means." Jason replied.

He turned and headed out of the room, only pausing to throw out one last line.

"Rest up. We'll meet tomorrow and see what your new MindCore can do."

Catherine nodded vigorously. "Okay! Thank you, Jason! Thank you..."

The door closed behind him, leaving Catherine alone in the hospital room. She stared forward, her mind in a daze.

"Was he always so handsome...?" She muttered to herself, while biting the tip of her thumb.

Part 703: RealitySim Online

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

It was Wednesday morning when Catherine woke up. As a Lazarite, she didn't need to sleep, but the MindCore operation had wiped out her mental resilience. After blearily showering in a fugue state, she collapsed face-first onto the bed in the bedroom Jason had made for her, adjoining the operating room, and fell fast asleep. When she woke up, there was a thick layer of drool on her pillow, which was incredibly mortifying for a dignified woman like herself.

Catherine carefully sat up on the bed. Despite more than 12 hours of sleep, she still felt somewhat tired. It was as if her mind was being slowed down by something, and that 'something' was clearly her MindCore. The problem was, she had no idea why.

Catherine unsteadily stood up. She leaned against the wall and walked along its edge toward the door. When she opened the door into the operating room, she found it was empty.

"Jas...on?" Catherine asked hesitantly.

Five seconds later, Jason appeared in his actual body, not a Dronesmith. The moment he saw her, Jason raised an eyebrow.

"Are you okay?"

Catherine shook her head. "Something's wrong. I feel dizzy and sleepy, but I don't usually- ah!"

She suddenly stumbled forward, collapsing into Jason's arms. For the briefest moment, both of them fell completely silent, feeling incredibly awkward, albeit for different reasons.

Jason helped her to a standing position and ushered her over to the operation chair. She sank into it, shuddering at the fact she'd been helpless once again. It was a good thing he hadn't taken advantage of her, or she didn't know how she would live with herself.

Jason, meanwhile, had zero intention of doing such a thing. He simply assumed that she was a prim and proper woman who didn't like being touched, so every time it

happened he felt a flash of guilt. As such, he quickly buried their interaction and forced a smile.

"I need to examine your MindCore. I probably overtuned the power consumption, so this should be a minor fix." Jason said.

Catherine nodded and looked away. She kept blushing, but she had no idea why. It was a maddening experience, and she felt like an idiot for being unable to understand her thoughts. She was extremely inexperienced when it came to worldly matters. Raphael had sheltered her for her entire life, and never had it been more apparent than now.

Jason used a Word of Power to examine Catherine's mind. What he found surprised him.

"Oh! I really screwed up. Good thing we caught this before you left or you probably would have... uh... let's not go into detail."

"What happened?" Catherine asked quietly.

Jason didn't respond at first. He instead focused on fixing the error, which thus allowed Catherine's mind to clear up.

Then, he leaned back and sighed with relief.

"Basically, your RealitySim can... simulate realities. Obviously. The problem is, when you fell asleep, all your dreams started being simulated, and due to the transient nature of dreams, you were creating one simulation after another, drastically overdrawing on your Faith Energy. If that had kept up, with you not being in Heaven where such energy is abundant and all..."

"I would have died." Catherine replied.

"You would have lasted a day or two in Aevum, maybe a few weeks if you returned to Heaven." Jason clarified. "Ultimately, you would have sucked all of Heaven's energy into yourself and maybe exterminated all of angelkind!"

Catherine's face blanched. She looked horrified by the possibility.

"W-why?!" She gasped. "Why would that happen??"

"Because." Jason answered. "Your MindCore simulates realities. Think about it. That can devour a *lot* of energy. If you attempted to simulate the existence of the entire universe, you would die on the spot. Simulating a planet is going to be quite taxing, a city

will be a little draining, and a singular fight or small-scale instance won't be any trouble. Since dream worlds can be vast or small, but ultimately random in nature, it definitely would have led to a bad ending."

Catherine calmed down. Jason's words were alarming, but now that she knew the risks, she could mitigate them by taking precautions.

"So what next?" Catherine asked. "How do I use my MindCore? Without killing myself, of course."

"You do it by taking small steps to acclimate your Inner World to the rest of your body." Jason said. "As you continue to simulate more and more realities, the efficiency and power drain will drop exponentially. You will be able to speed those simulations up faster and faster, allowing you to make great gains beyond your wildest dreams."

Jason waved his hand. "Here, I've been holding onto your original mental blueprints. Have them back. **Return.**"

By uttering a Word of Power, Jason sent hundreds of Blueprints Catherine had made over the course of her life back to her. Without them, she would have to construct each blueprint one by one. It wasn't as if she had forgotten the knowledge, but storing a 'hard file' inside her Mind Realm was far more effective than relying on her flawed biological brain's memory, with all its hallucinations and lapses in judgment.

Catherine looked within her Mind Realm. She felt awed by the giant planet filled with strange technology, magical artifacts, and other bizarre constructs Jason had implanted. Truth be told, if Jason had opted to subvert her Mind Realm and enslave her with some secret backdoor, she would be completely at his mercy. Inviting one's brain or Mind Realm for another to tamper with was extremely dangerous, as Raphael had told her many times.

She had no idea why she ultimately decided to trust Jason. Maybe it was because he was a Hero, like Joan. Catherine wasn't certain.

"I'd like to send my soul into your Mind Realm to show you around. Would that be okay with you?" Jason asked.

Catherine rubbed her hands together. "Of... course. You made my MindCore, after all."

"Don't feel that you owe me, or anyone, the right to enter your Mind Realm." Jason said, a tone of warning in his voice. "I cannot force my way in anymore. Your MindCore is

so advanced that if you reject my soul, you could cause me serious injury, or even kill me. If you're not 100% certain, you should tell me now."

Catherine's heart jumped. She felt that Jason was telling the truth, and the fact that he was putting himself in harm's way made her heart race for reasons she couldn't understand.

"No, I won't reject you." Catherine vowed. "Please show me how my MindCore works, Jason. I want to become powerful."

Jason smiled. "Alright. Let's both close our eyes and I'll transfer my soul."

And so they did. Man and woman closed their eyes and bowed their heads as if praying. Jason muttered a Word of Power.

"**Manifest.**"

His soul emerged from his body and floated toward Catherine. He slipped into her glabella, then arrived inside her Mind Realm without any issues. He felt surprised, expecting at least a little resistance, but it seemed Catherine had grown to fully trust him.

Catherine's soul also manifested inside her Mind Realm. She arrived standing beside Jason inside a massive stone temple with five-hundred-foot high walls, towering pillars that seemed to hold up the heavens, and statues of various Titans from across history lining the side walls. Catherine didn't even recognize some of them, but Jason knew their identities due to Solomon's visions of the Ancient Era.

"When I created your MindCore, I didn't name any of the regions or areas or major sites." Jason said, gesturing around. "It's up to you if you want to call them by any specific names."

Catherine gazed up at the gigantic statues with a feeling of awe. The craftsmanship was exquisite. She felt that if she studied them, she could make constructs capable of mimicking the depicted Titans' might.

"Who are all these Titans?" Catherine eventually asked.

"That small one over there is Hercules. He passed down the original Heroic Aura to Jepthath." Jason said, pointing to the smallest pair of statues near the entrance. "The woman beside him was his wife, Megara."

"Ah, and there's Zeus, not too far up the hill." Catherine acknowledged, nodding her head toward the Titan King's visage. "He is the current King of Titans... but who are all

these others?"

Jason led her to a vast hall with seats and tables that made the two humans look like ants. Far above, there were statues of Primordial Titans, their faces completely foreign to Catherine.

"At the head of the table is Odin, the Allmother." Jason said. "As far as I know, she was the oldest and most powerful of Titans. Did Raphael ever tell you about her?"

Catherine slowly shook her head. "We did not speak about Titans often, though I have met several over the centuries when I traveled alongside Raphael to broaden my horizons. I have even spoken to Zeus and Neptune in person."

Jason looked at her in surprise. "Neptune is alive? I thought he died during the Ancient Era."

"By no means." Catherine replied. "He has ruled Atlantis for several thousand years. What made you think he was dead?"

Jason scratched his chin. He remembered seeing the Archdemon crush Neptune's bones during the final battle, and assumed Neptune had died during Heaven's explosion.

"I guess the guy who told me got it wrong." Jason said with a shrug. He pointed at a female Titan, smaller than the others at the table. "And that one there, she is Ivaldi. Do you know her?"

When Catherine shook her head, Jason chuckled. "It seems Raphael doesn't educate you as well as I expected. Ivaldi was key in defeating the Archdemon during the War in Heaven. Her light magic nearly defeated the demons, and she was so powerful that the demons only won with a final hat trick by Satan."

Catherine looked at Jason in confusion. "What is an Archdemon? It sounds most ominous..."

Jason felt equally bewildered. "Seriously, for being Raphael's protege, he doesn't seem to tell you much of anything! Has he even mentioned the Ancient Era, the War in Heaven, or anything from around that period?"

"It simply... never came up." Catherine replied, though her tone quieted a little. Now that Jason mentioned it, it was a little strange how he hadn't mentioned matters of such grave importance. "I was always focused on improving my control over my Lazarite powers, so I didn't have much interest in history."

Jason gave her a strange look. "No interest in history? Catherine... are you lying to me?"

Catherine blushed. She quickly averted her eyes. "N-no. It just wasn't all that interesting... before now."

Jason fell silent. He realized Catherine *was* lying because her attitude was not one of someone uninterested in history. Who in her position wouldn't want to know about something as scary and awe-inspiring as the Archdemon? Who wouldn't want to hear tales of ancient battles and badass matchups between good and bad guys alike?

Raphael had clearly kept her in the dark for his own purposes, and Jason didn't like the idea of that. It would be best if he could slowly drip-feed information that changed Catherine's core beliefs and moved her away from the serpent manipulating her in the background.

"Well," Jason said, changing the subject, "this Hall of Titan Gods isn't only here for ornamental purposes. Titan King Odin's statue is actually a grand artifact that you can use to channel the full power of your MindCore. Let's try it out!"

Jason explained what Catherine needed to do, and she listened intently. He wasn't an expert on how things would actually work, but he knew the theory behind his design decisions.

After thirty minutes, Catherine readied herself. She activated Odin's statue and created a new world simulation!

Just like that, Catherine and Jason vanished and reappeared inside a simple white space. It was completely featureless, except for the squares that comprised the 'tiles' below their feet. Black lines forming those squares seemed to stretch out to infinity in every direction.

"Let's do a basic simulation." Jason said. "Remember when you fought Lucifer? Try creating a simulation of her physical appearance, strength, and powers."

Catherine nodded slowly. "Okay, I'll try. I don't really get the details, but it must be doable."

"I believe in you." Jason said with a smile.

Catherine tried not to let his smile distract her. She looked away, then focused her mind.

And then, just like that, Lucifer appeared. She stood completely still, staring vacantly at Jason and Catherine like a mindless robot.

"Next, make a simulation of yourself." Jason said.

Catherine nodded. A copy of herself appeared beside Lucifer.

"Alter Lucifer's simulation so that she acts like her real self. It doesn't have to be perfect, since you can't know everyone's inner self, but it can be close enough." Jason instructed. "Next, reorient Catherine-clone and Lucifer-clone so that they're facing each other. Then, have them fight."

Catherine followed along with Jason's commands. Soon, her other self and Lucifer's copy began to brawl. But it wasn't long before Lucifer blasted Catherine-clone to bits, killing her on the spot.

Shockingly, Catherine-clone bizarrely kept fighting! Even though her limbs were blown apart, they levitated in the air and continued to fight.

"Why... what... how is that happening?" Catherine asked, confused.

"This is a simulation of reality. You have to dictate how realistic the simulation is." Jason explained. "Your clone doesn't know what 'dying' means because you haven't programmed the basic laws of nature into your reality. Luckily for you, I already programmed a fairly precise representation of physics into your MindCore. Just check on Sub-node 115-A and toggle it to 'True'."

* * *

An hour later, Jason had helped Catherine create a lush jungle and valley with rising mountains, where her copy and Lucifer could run, jump, and fly around, chasing and fighting one another.

Every time Catherine-clone clashed with Lucifer-clone, Catherine lost. Lucifer was far too powerful, and Catherine couldn't get an edge.

"Why am I not able to learn from what's happening?" Catherine eventually asked. "Didn't you say I could make these simulations train me to be stronger?"

"You can't yet because you haven't set up a neural feedback loop." Jason explained. "You aren't able to learn from your clone or anything else until you code your MindCore to reboot once in a while and transfer the knowledge gained from the simulations back to your brain. But be careful! You don't want to transfer a bunch of garbage data; only the

pertinent stuff. Otherwise, you might download eight million thoughts from the fish in that lake over there."

Catherine laughed. "Hahaha! I've always wondered what it would be like to be a fish! Glub glub!"

Jason smiled back. She rarely laughed, but when she did, he couldn't help but find himself attracted to her.

After a moment, he quickly cleared his throat and steeled his mind, returning to a serious expression.

"The next step is to make a simulated version of yourself that oversees these simulations." Jason explained. "This 'AI' should be simplistic and non-sentient. It should only have the purpose of observing simulations and transferring desired information to your brain after each simulation has run its course."

Catherine nodded. "Okay, let's do that, then."

* * *

Several more hours passed. Time seemed to disappear like dust in the wind. Jason found that he was having a lot of fun spending time with Catherine, and she was likewise truly enjoying herself as well. It wasn't just that they were experiencing transcendent simulated worlds together, but that they were forging a connection by building Catherine up. The more she learned, the more formidable she became.

"So the next step-" Jason started to say, only for Catherine to interrupt him.

"-is to speed up the production process." Catherine said, rolling her eyes cutely at him. "Yes, I can see that."

Before her, there were five different Catherine-clones. Each one was holding onto a blueprint-in-progress and slowly adding new bits and pieces to it as they experimented with ways to create weapons and armor.

Jason examined one of the weapons. It appeared to be a long-barreled hunting rifle of some sort, but it was a bit different from any he had seen.

"That clone is using one of my older designs and trying to modernize it." Catherine explained. "I could simply steal the blueprint of a rifle some other human has made, but when I summon it as a light construct, it will have magical power, so I'd rather make better use of that function."

Jason nodded. "If you empower your weapons and armors with divine energy, they'll shoot faster and hit harder than any mundane weapon. It's a good choice."

Catherine became quiet for a moment.

"Jason..." She said slowly. "You said before that it might be a good idea for me to bring on a couple other Lazarites to serve as Blueprinters for me. Do you still think that's a good idea?"

Jason widened his eyes. "Of course! Are you seriously considering it now? I promise that if you have anyone in mind, I'll do my best to help uplift them to your level."

"Good. That's good." Catherine said, before hesitantly lowering her eyes. "It's just... I feel a little guilty. You've given me so much, and I've done nothing for you in return."

"You're giving me a lot of data regarding the MindCore." Jason retorted. "And you accepted the risk of being my first experimental subject. That took a lot of guts."

"Still..." Catherine said, twiddling her thumbs shyly. "I've, um... I've decided... I won't tell Raphael about any of this. Not about my MindCore, or you, or anything else. In fact, I won't tell anyone at all. I'll keep it a secret for now."

Jason was surprised. "Why the change of heart?"

"Because... you've been so good to me. And I can't help but think maybe you have a point... about Raphael." Catherine said quietly. "I've known him far longer than I've known you, but I can't help thinking now that his motives were impure."

"My motives could be equally impure." Jason pointed out.

Catherine looked up into Jason's eyes. She clutched her hands against her chest and let out a small sigh. "Maybe so... but I'm fine with that... as long as it's you."

A long moment of silence followed. Jason swallowed heavily. The way she was looking at him felt a little... but that was impossible.

He quickly averted his eyes. "Haha... you say strange things sometimes."

"I'm being sincere." Catherine said quietly, still looking up at the side of his face. "I've decided that, at least for now, I want to... follow you."

Jason licked his lips. He closed his eyes and pressed his fingers against his eyelids.

"Catherine..." Jason said, his voice soft. "I can't. I just can't. You're beautiful, but my wife..."

"I'm sorry." Catherine said, quickly looking away. "I know she passed away not too long ago. It was wrong of me to say such a thing. My shame is immeasurable."

Jason pulled his hands away and opened his eyes. "No, no, it's not like that. See... I told you I came from the future, right? But my wife is... she's *alive* in this time. She won't know who I am. She won't remember me. But she's trapped under the spell of a monster named Bahamut. I know she won't remember me, but still I have to save her. And maybe, if I act correctly, I can... rekindle... what I lost."

Jason's expression fell after he spoke. He turned his whole body to the side and heaved a great sigh.

"But I don't know if I deserve it. I don't know if it would be right. My wife won't remember me. She died because of my incompetence. What is the point of rekindling a flame with her past self when I failed her in the future? I don't know what to do. It's eating me up inside."

Catherine pursed her lips. "Phoebe must have been an extraordinary woman for you to remain so faithful. I truly envy her."

"She was extraordinary, indeed." Jason replied. "She *is*."

After another moment of silence, Catherine swept a hand through her hair. "Forget what I said. I apologize for my impropriety. But I will keep your secrets safe. I won't speak of Aevum, the MindCore, or your powers to anyone who has no reason to know."

"Thank you." Jason said, smiling sincerely again. "I really do appreciate that. The stakes are high, after all."

"Yes they are." Catherine replied. "But Raphael is intelligent. He will eventually notice my enhanced capabilities."

Jason glanced at Catherine. He looked away.

"Catherine. There's... there's something I haven't told you."

Her heart skipped a beat. She turned to look at Jason with a mixed expression comprised of many different emotions. "You haven't told me... what?"

"It's about Raphael." Jason said, massaging his right arm with his left. "He tampered with your Mind Realm."

Silence.

Catherine looked at Jason with deep shock. "He... he did? No! He wouldn't! How can you utter such an accusation?"

"He did." Jason said quietly. "When I scoured your Mind Realm, I found the anomaly immediately. Raphael had put a homing beacon on you so he would know where you were on Earth at all times. You've been in Aevum for weeks now, which isn't long in realspace terms, but it's definitely been long enough for Raphael to sense your presence disappearing."

Jason paused.

"...It's also possible he traced Aevum's location when I brought you here, though I can't say for certain. Either way, when you return to Earth, his transponder will no longer be functioning, and he will know."

Catherine looked aghast. "Do you have any proof?"

"Sure." Jason said. "I copied the fragment of your Mind Realm where I found the transponder. Take a look."

With a wave of his hand, he passed it over to Catherine, and her expression turned ugly.

"So... he really..."

"Yeah." Jason said. "I'm sorry. I wasn't going to tell you before, because I assumed you were going to go back to Raphael and tell him at least some of what you went through. But if you go back now, he'll definitely notice you're hiding something from him."

Catherine shifted uneasily on her feet. "I... I do not know how to feel right now. I don't know what to do. I am at a loss..."

"You could stay here." Jason suggested. "I can easily replenish your Faith Energy. Or you can return to Earth, and thus Heaven. If you want to return, I could give you a few life preserving measures, just in case."

"What is your meaning?" Catherine asked. "Do you believe that just because my transponder is removed, Raphael might wish to harm me?"

Jason held up his hands helplessly.

"I don't know. I just want to make sure you're safe."

A feeling of warmth spread throughout Catherine's body. She looked away, feeling her face heat up. She found that she quite enjoyed being spoken to in such a manner by the man before her.

"Then, in that case, I'll take your protective charm with me." Catherine said, unable to look him in the eye.

He looked like a young man, barely eighteen years old, with no muscle on his body to speak of, yet the way he spoke had slowly come to captivate her.

The two of them resumed their work, and eventually, Jason pulled out of her Mind Realm to return to reality.

"Alright, Catherine. I think you've understood the important concepts. It'll be up to you to experiment with your MindCore for the next week. When you think you're ready, I'll send you back to Earth. It'd also be great if you could maybe write up a document for me about your experience so I can pass it on to the next person I give a RealitySim... and that'll probably be Nadia."

Catherine chewed her lower lip. "Of course. I'd love to. It's just..."

"Something wrong?" Jason asked.

"No, not at all!" Catherine exclaimed. "Jason, you can, um, you can call me 'Cath'. That's how all my friends refer to me."

"Oh, sure!" Jason said with a smile. "Cath. That's a cute name."

Catherine blushed again. "I like hearing it from you the most. See you tomorrow?"

"Sure thing, Cath." Jason said, turning to leave. "See you tomorrow."

After that, he vanished, teleporting back to Aevum's core.

Once he was gone, Catherine's face heated up even more than before.

What nickname, *Cath*? Nobody had ever called her something cutesy like that before. If anyone but the Archangels had tried, she might have slapped their faces off!

But she felt it was fine, so long as it was Jason who said it.

"You know, Joan..." Catherine muttered to herself quietly. "...even if he does find his wife again... I'm okay with staying on the side and watching from afar. I'm happy as long as I'm in his presence."

She giggled.

"I wonder if you would approve?"

Part 704: Survivor's Guilt

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Jason sat in his meditation chamber within the heart of Aevum. His four Spiritual Incarnations were not present, as he had recalled them back into his soul. He did this so he could maintain full awareness and focus during Catherine's surgery, but in the end, he still badly exhausted himself and realized he would need several days to fully recuperate. He had put on a brave face for Catherine just a short while earlier while introducing her to the RealitySim's functions, but now that he was alone, he began to feel tired beyond words.

The Wordsmith wasn't only tired, though. There was another feeling flooding his body, and it worsened by the hour.

He realized that this feeling was a deep, inescapable well of depression.

Sitting alone, with no sounds to disturb him, the quiet silence of his Sanctum gave rise to emotions Jason usually didn't allow himself to feel.

Mainly, he felt guilt.

Deep, unquenchable guilt.

As he stared lifelessly at the ground, Jason felt a hollowness in his heart that had existed since the moment his wife died, and had never gone away, but at times seemed it might be on its way out the door. Only, all at once, out of the blue, it would come roaring back, growing more powerful than at any other time before.

He was depressed. He knew this. He could tell it was the case, but he didn't know how to make the feeling go away.

Every time Jason thought he might be able to feel some measure of happiness or contentment again, his depression came roaring back, rocking him to his core. Sometimes, when he was all alone, he wept uncontrollably. Other times he simply stared vacantly ahead, unable to think of anything at all, like now.

The reason Jason felt guilty was anything but simple. It was a circle of suffering that fed upon itself like an ouroboros.

Jason had failed to save his wife. She died because of his incapability.

He didn't know what had killed her. This devastated him more than anything else, because so long as he didn't know, he could never prevent it from happening again. Sometimes he thought Gressil had killed her, but other times he wondered if maybe she had a heart attack, or was secretly struck by some insidious attack from the shadows... an attack Jason could have prevented if he had been there for her.

Only a day earlier, Jason felt that he had enjoyed uplifting Catherine a little too much. The sight of her body had roused something sleeping within him, but then the guilt of Phoebe's death came crashing back down upon him, debilitating his mental state further than ever.

Why should he be allowed to enjoy himself? Why should he be allowed to move on? Wasn't he a Hero with a power greater than any before him? How could he dare to laugh and smile when he had failed the most important person in his life?

His daughter was alive.

So what?

It wasn't as if he had saved her. She survived only through a stroke of luck. A beam of light the universe shone upon her. Not because of her useless father's hands.

Jason was working to save humanity and Earth from a dark future.

But so what?

Why did he care? Because people would look up to him? The man who failed his own wife? Why did he deserve any accolades? He was only doing now what he should have done in the past.

He was a useless imbecile playing God.

It wasn't as if Jason was a Chosen One. His father had made sure he knew that much. Jason and Hideki were *thieves*. They had stolen the power of the Heroic Aura and taken it upon themselves to become Earth's Heroes.

But who said they deserved to be Heroes? More likely, the Heroic Aura would have chosen someone more suitable than two loser rat bastards who both failed to save their own wives.

Hideki had failed to save Olivia, and Jason had failed to save Phoebe. Like father, like son.

Jason sat in place, his mind spinning, his emotions turbulent. He held his knees tightly, squeezing them while wishing he could break his own bones to make the emotional agony stop.

The last two days had hurt him more than any before. He felt that he had already begun to cheat on Phoebe by entertaining any thoughts of spending time with Catherine. But why did he deserve to enjoy himself?

Jason balled his right hand into a fist. He trembled for a moment, then violently punched himself in the face!

Then he struck himself again. And again!

Tears flowed from his eyes. He gritted his teeth and let out a cry. Not from the physical pain, but from the mental pain that he couldn't release. He felt as if a valve had been tightened, preventing the flow of water, but no matter what direction he twisted and turned it, that water would never flow! It defied all logic!

He started punching himself with both hands. He threw himself to the floor and banged his forehead against it, over and over. He became so violent that if his daughter had witnessed his rage, she would have been horrified beyond compare.

"Aaahh!!"

Jason screamed and cried. He clutched his aching face and wept uncontrollably.

He wanted the pain to end. He wanted it to end so badly that he even considered taking his own life.

But even that thought sent him into another mental spiral.

How *dare* he consider suicide? His daughter needed him. Wasn't he pathetic, wanting to take the easy way out after failing his wife? What would Phoebe think, knowing he had abandoned his little girl to a future where she would definitely meet an end at the demon's claws?

She would hate him. He knew that much.

But then again, she would hate him for abandoning his son. That was another thing that ripped Jason's psyche in half. He had left Timothy in an uncertain future, a timeline that no longer existed because of Jason's actions.

He could never see his son again! Jason knew this to be true!

Jason clawed at his eyes.

He hated himself!

He hated himself so goddamned much!!

He wanted to die! But he couldn't, because he didn't deserve to die! But he didn't deserve to atone either! And he didn't deserve the glory for any future accomplishments, because those were what he should have been doing right from the very start!!!

Eventually, Jason's rage abated. He returned to a sitting position, staring vacantly at the floor.

Blood dripped from his forehead.

Bruises began to swell on his face.

Scrapes covered his knuckles.

But none of them took the edge off the true pain buried deep within.

Jason healed himself. He returned to pristine physical form, then heaved a long, quiet sigh.

He had to get back to work. He did his best to try and shut out the voices of self-hatred and put on the smile he had been wearing like a mask.

A mask...

Jason chuckled lifelessly.

Was this how his father felt? Failing to save his wife, rewind after rewind, until the life left his eyes?

Was Hideki's entire demeanor a falsehood reinforced by the mask he wore?

Was he still Hideki, or had he long ago become Cat Mask in both name and spirit?

Jason didn't know. He did not have the answers.

* * *

Jason stood up. He thought to himself for a moment, then he uttered a Word of Power, teleporting to the room where his daughter and her friends were training.

When Jason arrived, the others didn't immediately notice him. He stayed still and observed the scene from a distance.

It turned out everyone was focused on helping Sasha improve her skills in Alchemy. They were watching as she changed piles of fabric Jason had given her into various cute dresses, which either Daisy or Nadia would leave for a short while, head into the dressing room, and come back out wearing.

Judging by the huge pile of clothes she had already made, it was obvious she had a lot of passion for tailoring.

But that wasn't all. It turned out her affinity for clothing also translated to armor. Daisy had been mainly requesting differently shaped sets of armor from various eras of history, while Nadia was the one who wore all the dresses.

And to top it all off, Marco hadn't been neglected. Sasha had made various diverse outfits for him as well, though for some reason she chose to go for a more 'costume heavy' route. She had made him shiny silver space armor from old 50's TV shows, Renaissance outfits that looked like they belonged in a Shakespeare play, and various different superhero outfits. It seemed Marco was really into reading comics and had given Sasha lots of different ones for inspiration.

Jason slowly meandered forward, at which point Daisy turned to notice him.

"Dad!"

Her single word caught everyone's attention. They turned to look at him.

"How did the operation go?" Nadia asked. "Is the angel lady... okay?"

"She's just fine." Jason said with a smile. "Heaven's Daughter is taking some time to learn how her MindCore works. I plan to operate on you next, Nadia, but first I'd like you to spend a little time with her so she can explain the RealitySim's intricacies. Maybe the two of you can rub your brains together and improve her abilities before she returns to Heaven."

Marco seemed to be in a daze. "Return to Heaven... it's so bizarre hearing you say that casually, Mister Hiro. Like, it's *Heaven*, you know? It's Heaven!"

"Heaven's not anything like what you'd expect." Jason said sardonically. "I'd even go so far as to say it's kind of shitty, and definitely a letdown. All those Sunday sermons preaching about eternal happiness, but really when you die you just become a slave and a meatshield for the pureblooded angels."

Nadia raised an eyebrow. "It seems as if you don't like the angels. But if not, why help Heaven's Daughter? Doesn't that hurt you in the long run?"

Jason swept his gaze around all the teenagers. They looked at him with curious gazes.

"Let's get one thing out of the way." Jason said sternly. "Heaven is almost entirely comprised of Lazarites, which are humans raised from death into angelic bodies. I don't have exact numbers, but you can safely assume at this point 99.99% of all angels are Lazarites. Heaven's Daughter is the 'Strongest Lazarite', so she's the strongest of all the humans there."

He continued. "It's the pureblooded angels I don't like, because they rule over the Lazarites and their motives are not pure. But more specifically, it's not even the purebloods, but the Archangels. And not all of them, but just one. Raphael is the ruler of Heaven, the oldest Archangel, and an absolute snake. If you ever have the misfortune of meeting him, assume he is lying to you whenever his mouth opens."

"Well if Raphael is the one you hate, then why act like a large number of angels are the problem?" Daisy asked, crossing her arms and looking at her dad quizzically. "He's only one angel among many, right?"

"No, because Raphael has an iron grip on Heaven." Jason explained. "He has completely captivated them and made them think he's this amazing genius, wise beyond knowledge, and even given himself the arrogant title 'Archangel of Wisdom.' But after spending a long time learning about him, I've personally decided a more appropriate title would be 'Archangel of Greed.' Raphael desires power above all else, and the 'kindly old man' role he plays is a façade meant to disguise the rot infesting his soul."

"Never trust Raphael." Jason concluded. "He smiles, but the expression is hollow. His eyes appear kindly, but they are evil and devious. Because of him, the angels wield a power that could be turned against humanity through deception, or perhaps even by force. After all, Raphael isn't a weak old man at all. He's an Archangel, and one who wields extreme power. Perhaps only Gabriel, Michael, or Camael can hold a candle to him if they came to blows. Thus we must assume that if we disregard Heaven, it could stab us in the back at Raphael's behest someday."

The teenagers nodded seriously.

"Sounds like a bastard." Marco muttered.

"You said it." Sasha added, chuckling at Marco slightly.

After a moment, Jason clapped his hands.

"Okay. Well, I'm going to bring Heaven's Daughter here. She told me she would write up a document about her experiences with the RealitySim, and once I've uplifted Nadia, I'll be able to move on to the rest of you."

"When are you installing Nadia's MindCore?" Daisy asked. "And can I go after her?"

"Not this time." Jason said. "I want to get Nadia online first because her power is going to be instrumental in improving a lot of Aevum's facets, drawing up plans for the future, and she'll add diversity to the types of intelligence we have on hand. I'd actually rather empower Sasha next, because her ability seems really useful for crafting and building things. Then it'll be between you and Marco."

"I can go last." Marco said, raising a palm in deference. "I ain't jazzed about any of this, and I still think my power ain't all that amazing. It's pretty limited. I'd rather the girls get stronger first."

Marco's self-esteem, as always, provided a window into his thoughts. Jason slightly nodded at Marco, but he felt it was a pity. Marco still didn't get how crazy the power to snap enemies into another dimension was. Jason still needed to learn the intricacies of how it worked, but he was worried creating dimensions inside a stabilized space like Aevum was a bad idea. He planned to have Marco continue training in Realspace, on a world somewhere far from the Volgrim and humans alike. That would be the safest bet.

"Alright. So the order will be Nadia, Sasha, Daisy, and then Marco." Jason said. "But Nadia, it'll be a few days. I need to make some adjustments to the installation procedure, since I think it didn't go as smoothly as I would have liked with Heaven's Daughter."

"What went wrong?" Nadia asked.

Jason leaned against a pillar in the middle of the room and crossed his arms. "When Mildred guided me into installing my own MindCore, the process was excruciating beyond description. I nearly died multiple times. Because I had to- well, just imagine a doctor performing brain surgery on himself. Not a pretty thought, is it?"

Nadia shook her head, and Jason continued.

"Anyway, I thought that since I was doing the procedure on someone else, and since I had improved and simplified the MindCore installation process, while Heaven's Daughter

was also a powerful Lazarite, she would be able to easily bear with the pain. But I was wrong. I didn't realize her tolerance for pain was lower than mine, so I had to change gears mid-operation. I switched her neurons to reroute them from pain to pleasure. Err, the operation stopped being life threatening, but too much pleasure for too long would be..."

"It would cause plenty of ill effects." Nadia said, finishing his words for him. Her eyes glowed as she absorbed the information. "Why didn't you try dulling the pain instead with your Word Magic?"

"Couldn't." Jason said. "I'd need to iterate on the RealitySim further, figure out how to make the operation itself less painful. In the heat of the moment, the best thing I could think of was swapping her neural pathways. Most of the 'pain' comes from the soul after all, not the actual brain."

"Did you record the procedure?" Nadia asked.

Jason blinked. "Uh... no. Why?"

"Because I'd like to watch it myself. I might be able to glean some insights, help you improve future MindCore procedures." Nadia explained.

Jason scratched his chin. "Well... I guess I *did* record it from my point of view. My MindCore has a perfect recording, including my outlines and actions taken before and during the operation. But I'd want to get her permission first."

"Please ask." Nadia said, smiling at him. "I might be able to help, and obviously I'd like to make sure I and the others don't have to suffer too much pain when you operate on all of us."

After taking care of some other matters, Jason paused before he left.

"By the way. I'm going to be bringing some more people into Aevum tomorrow. They're about the same age as the rest of you, so I hope you guys can become good friends with them."

"More people?" Marco asked. "Who?"

"Some people I met while I was with the Illuminati." Jason said. "A guy named Brian Bozzard, another named Jerome Nguyen, a girl named Farrah Lapis, and a few others. In time, I might give them MindCores too, but we'll have to see. Mainly, I just want to bring them to safety and give them a way to train their combat abilities for the future war."

"So... all of them are Lowborn Heroes too?" Daisy asked.

"That's right. As for whether or not you uplifted them, or someone else? I'm not sure." Jason replied.

The teens looked at one another and nodded. Making new friends sounded great, and Marco seemed interested in the fact that two of them were guys. Not that he didn't enjoy hanging out with a bunch of cute girls, but balancing the scales of gender a bit sounded nice.

"Anyway," Jason concluded, "you all just keep working on mastering your powers. I'll see Nadia in a few days once I'm ready, and in the meantime I'll bring Heaven's Daughter over to introduce her."

Jason turned to leave. Before he could vanish, Daisy called out.

"Hey dad, wait!"

She teleported over to him and touched his shoulder. Jason smiled.

"What's the matter, honey?"

Daisy pulled him aside, a little further away from the other teens. Seeing that she wanted privacy with her father, they returned to what they were doing before, and she lowered her voice.

"Dad... are you doing okay?"

Jason was surprised. "Of course. Why?"

"It's just... you seem a little down today." Daisy said, her tone somewhat uncertain.

"Oh. I'm just tired from the surgery." Jason said. "It was pretty exhausting and all."

"I'm sure it was..." Daisy said, frowning ever so slightly. "But dad, you know you can talk to me, right? I'm not a little girl anymore."

Jason's expression flickered. He touched Daisy's hand with his own, as she was still holding his shoulder. He smiled, but the expression seemed a little hollow.

"I know you're not, Daisy. That's something I can't forget."

Daisy fell silent. She lowered her eyes.

"Are you still beating yourself up over the past, dad? You don't... have to do that. Everyone makes mistakes. I don't blame you at all."

"You might not blame me for anything." Jason said, after a moment of thought. "But that doesn't mean I don't."

A moment of silence followed. Jason turned his gaze away to stare the far wall.

"There are some problems even the greatest magic can't fix. I have to go, sweetheart. I'll be back later."

"Dad, if this is about mom-" Daisy started to say, but her father pulled her hand away.

"Let's talk about this later." Jason said, closing her off. "Now's not a good time. I have too much on my plate."

Without waiting for a response, Jason vanished, teleporting elsewhere into Aevum.

Daisy stood, motionless, feeling a sense of nausea swell in her stomach. It was only now that she realized things were not as they seemed.

Her father had tried to play it off, but even if Daisy could not read his thoughts, she had long ago learned to read other humans well. She could tell his mental situation was worsening by the day, but she hadn't noticed until now just how far he had deteriorated.

He always seemed so upbeat and hopeful, so certain of what had to be done. But what if all of this was simply a coping mechanism? What if the man she looked up to the most wasn't a superhuman?

What if he was only human?

Daisy chewed her lower lip tentatively for a moment. She swallowed her saliva, then turned to shakily stride back over to the rest. When they asked her if she was okay, she brushed away their complaints and forced herself to get back on track mentally.

Like father, like daughter.

Part 705: Respect+

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Two more days passed inside Aevum, which amounted to less than 10 minutes in the outside world. Catherine had already been inside Aevum for one real world hour or so, but for the demons preparing to move on Mount Sinai, they had barely even traded potshots with the outermost sentries and Lazarites.

Catherine wrote up a short document as Jason had requested, detailing the functions of her MindCore and how the RealitySim functioned. At least according to her limited experience with it. She would need a lot more time to grow intimately familiar with its intricacies.

Catherine met with Jason's daughter and the others, but she wore her full armor, refused to let them see her face, and did not give them her real name. It seemed she had only done so with Jason because of reasons she didn't care to explain. Then she returned to her quarters to continue training with her RealitySim.

Eventually, Jason brought in a dozen new Lowborn Heroes from the Illuminati. When they arrived, greetings were exchanged all around.

"Hello, everyone. I am Brian Bozzard. It is my pleasure to meet all of you." Brian said, flashing a dazzling smile at the girls. It didn't take a rocket scientist to see he favored relations with the fairer sex more.

Brian wore a snazzy blue pinstripe suit with a red tie. He dressed up like a politician, and his ability with words was equally impressive.

"Hi, Brian!" Sasha exclaimed. "I'm Sasha! You're really handsome!"

"I do get that a lot." Brian said, flashing an even brighter smile at her.

"Nadia." Nadia said, brusquely introducing herself with one word.

"I'm Marco." Marco said, smiling a bit less than Sasha, but much more than Nadia. "It's good to meet you."

"Brian." Daisy said, crossing her arms. "Remember me?"

Brian took a moment to look at her before his eyes lit up.

"Ohh, yes! You are- um, what was it again? Dandy? The daughter of Vasily Sokolov?"

"Daisy. And he's my adopted uncle, not my father." Daisy replied. "My dad is Jason Hiro."

Brian's expression faltered. He slowly directed a look of horror toward Jason.

"B-b-but... you two are p-p-practically the same age! Oh heavens, how did that happen?! You poor boy, Jason!"

Jason slapped his face. "It's not like that. I'm a lot older than I look. I'll explain it to you some other time."

Brian seemed visibly relieved. "Oh, good. Good! I was suddenly so very worried for you, for a second there."

Everyone had a good laugh, then the other newcomers introduced themselves.

"I'm Farrah..." The young blonde girl said, fidgeting uncomfortably as multiple people's gazes fell on her. "I, um, I can change my... my face... a little..."

"She's a shapeshifter." Jason explained.

"Oh! That's an awesome ability!" Daisy quickly praised. "My dad told me only Belial could do that. Your power is really unique!"

Marco smiled at Farrah. "Is there anyone you usually like turning into?"

Jerome, standing next to Farrah, glowered at Marco. He didn't seem to like it when he perceived other guys making moves on 'his girl.' He wrapped his arm around Farrah's shoulder, which seemed to ease her nerves a bit.

"I turn into, um, movie stars sometimes. Singers. Celebrities. I like turning into Marilyn Monroe."

Her face and hair changed, and she suddenly morphed into a nearly perfect facsimile of a young Marilyn Monroe from the 1960's. Everyone exclaimed in surprise due to how quickly che had changed. Unfortunately, only her face changed, not her voice and personality.

"I'm Jerome Nguyen." The tallest young man in the room said. Jerome appeared to have grown another inch or two since Jason last saw him. He was an absolute mountain of a man. He towered over his girlfriend by two full heads, standing at well over six and a half feet tall. "I'm the toughest motherfucker here."

He paused, before lightly bobbing his head in Jason's direction. "Though Jason did kick my ass. I'll admit that much."

"Jerome." Jason said, causing the dark skinned Titan of a man to look in his direction. "You know my daughter Daisy is a Trueborn too, right?"

"What?" Jerome said, turning to look at her in surprise. "She is- you are?"

He directed the last two words at Daisy directly. When Brian and Farrah also looked at Daisy in shock, this caused Sasha, Nadia, and Marco to be taken aback. They didn't fully understand what a concept a 'Trueborn Hero' was, whereas these kids who had been partially raised by the Illuminati knew it well. In their eyes, there was a vast chasm between a Lowborn and a Trueborn.

Jerome immediately pulled away from Farrah. "Are you a Trueborn?"

Daisy nodded. "If my dad says I am, then I am."

"Then we've gotta fight." Jerome said without hesitation. "I'm the strongest Lowborn. Only your dad has beaten me. If you beat me, I'll acknowledge you."

Daisy raised an eyebrow. She crossed her arms and smirked. "Who says I need your validation?"

"If you have any guts, you'll fight me." Jerome said, taking a step toward her. His body absolutely towered over her.

"Hey!" Marco shouted. "Don't you think picking on a girl half your size is unmanly?"

"I don't give a shit about my opponent's gender. My challenge shows respect." Jerome shot back, barely even looking at Marco. "That's a word you could stand to learn, little guy."

"You...!" Marco started to say, before swallowing his words. He thought to himself that if things came to blows, he'd end up dying to Jerome. The man was seriously scary to look at.

Daisy took a step forward. "If you want to challenge me, that's fine. I don't know which of us will win, but... are you *sure* you want to fight?"

"Of course. I'm not ashamed of losing. I don't get a big ego just 'cause I win. I simply like to fight." Jerome answered.

Daisy nodded. "Then, dad? Make us an arena."

* * *

Shortly afterward, Jason had summoned an arena underground beneath Aevum's soil. He hadn't yet had a chance to show off the new world to the Illuminati's young potentates, but he was already setting up a fight between his daughter and the monster of a man named Jerome.

Despite the young man's physical bulk and imposing size, Jason wasn't worried. He had fought Jerome before and sized him up. He had also made some vague determinations about Daisy, so he felt she had a good shot at winning. But in truth, he'd never seen his daughter fight before.

As Jerome wrapped his hands and prepared for a fight on the opposite corner of the ring, Jason met up with his daughter. She had changed into a sports bra and boxing shorts while also taking time to wrap her own hands.

"Honey?" Jason asked. "Are you going to be okay?"

Daisy nodded. "I've done a lot of training, and I've fought a lot of people. I have a dozen different ways to take down a lunkhead, though he's definitely much stronger than any other human I've met."

"I don't know exactly *how* strong Jerome is." Jason said quietly. "But he probably has enough strength to pick up and throw a car several blocks. You know weight classes exist for a reason, right? He isn't just multiple weight classes above you; he's also superhumanly strong. Are you *absolutely* sure you can handle this?"

Daisy gave him a smile. "Dad. I've got this. No worries."

Jason sighed. He strolled over to the center of the ring, then waited for Daisy and Jerome to both walk over as well.

"The rules are simple." "Jason said. "The goal is to knock or throw your opponent to the ground. If you can pin them to the ground for five seconds, or if you can ring them out, you win. Winning three of five rounds is your goal. Make this a clean fight, no beating the shit out of each other. Got it?"

Jerome nodded. He smiled, and there was a hint of arrogance. "Don't worry, Trueborn. I won't hurt your little girl."

Daisy snorted. "We'll see who's hurting by the end of this."

Jason took a few steps back. He held up his arm.

"Ready! Three, two, one, fight!"

He karate chopped the side of his palm down, and Jerome immediately lunged forward!

Jerome grabbed at Daisy's shoulders, intending to hurl her to the floor with one smooth movement. Before his hands could make contact...

Foop!

Daisy vanished! She reappeared a half-meter off the ground, right behind Jerome. With one leg coiled like a viper, she kicked at Jerome with the flat of her foot and sent him toppling forward!

Jerome was shocked! He landed on his elbows and quickly jumped back up.

"You... how did you...?"

"Teleportation." Daisy answered. "Better watch out for it."

Daisy hopped from side to side, keeping her palms up in front of her face. Jerome charged again, but he was a little more hesitant this time, expecting her to teleport once more.

Instead, Daisy kicked the ground with her feet and did a strange slide-glide motion as she seemed to roll forward, right under Jerome's grasp. Her movements somehow defied physics, and he was caught unprepared. Jerome grabbed wildly at Daisy's body as she slid underneath his legs, but she grabbed his ankle and pulled back on it mid-step, causing him to tumble to the mat once again.

Unfortunately, dropping Jerome to the mat was one thing, but keeping him pinned there was another. Daisy didn't even try. She had no chance of holding him on the ground for a few seconds. Her body weight would be like a toothpick in his hands if he got serious.

Jerome leaped to his feet again. He gave her a strange glance and spun around, looking her up and down with more interest.

"Was that another power?" Jerome asked.

"Something like that." Daisy replied noncommittally.

The two started dancing around each other. Daisy was much nimbler than Jerome, making him look like a clumsy oaf by comparison. But he wasn't. Jerome was just as well-

trained as her, and each ability she revealed gave him more information to work with.

Daisy was a generalist. Jerome was a Specialist. He didn't have many tricks up his sleeve, but he was very good at dealing with things in specific ways.

Daisy suddenly flickered to the right, then to the left. She quick-teleported, causing Jerome to lose sight of her for a moment.

Suddenly, she appeared behind Jerome and kicked at the back of his neck!

But Jerome abruptly ducked, then snapped his hand up behind himself. He grabbed Daisy by the leg, making her yelp in fright. He swung her overhead, but slowed the throw toward the end, instead *plopping* her onto the mat and grabbing her other leg to hold her in place.

Unable to break free, Daisy gave up and gave Jerome the first point.

He released her legs, and she grimaced, massaging her ankles and knees. His grip was incredibly strong!

"Don't use the same tricks twice on me." Jerome warned. "They won't work."

Daisy stood up. She looked around and saw that many people were fawning over Jerome, excited by his simple brutish power. There really was something appealing about seeing a guy who could just beat the shit out of people, especially when he was built like a brick shithouse. Even Sasha was seeing stars in her eyes. She had a thing for big strong men, it seemed.

Daisy cracked her neck. "You want me to use a new trick then?"

"If you have them, use them." Jerome said flatly. "If you're going easy on me, don't. My pride can take it. I'm not afraid of losing face."

Daisy felt a bit of surprise at his words. She found his attitude commendable. There was something appealing about someone who liked to fight for fighting's sake.

"I'm still going to go easy on you in this round." Daisy said. "But next round, I'm going to get serious."

Jerome frowned. "That is not wise."

"We'll see." Daisy replied.

When Jason started the second round, it was Daisy who suddenly charged at Jerome. He raised an eyebrow, not expecting her to do something so dumb. Her powers were

versatile, but if she got within grabbing range, it was all over!

Jerome realized it was probably a trick she'd use before teleporting away, but he decided to take the bait anyway. He grabbing at Daisy, but when his hands made contact with her shoulders... they passed through!

He swept his palms right through where she was standing, as if she had turned into a ghost! Daisy ran through his body, making question marks pop up above his head. Jerome turned around to look for her, but Daisy wasn't there! She didn't appear to be on the stage at all!

Suddenly, Jerome's right leg was swept out from the side. He yelped as he started to fall to the ground, but he quickly caught himself by slapping his right palm against the ground.

When he looked for Daisy, he didn't see her! Had she turned invisible?

A sudden kick to Jerome's back sent him tumbling forward. It was that damned teleportation trick again!

Jerome tried to grab behind himself, but she was gone. He still couldn't see her!

Meanwhile, Jason and the others stared at the scene in disbelief. For some reason, at the start of the round, Daisy had stood still, and Jerome had started grabbing at the air. Then Daisy ran over and swept his leg, then walked around him and kicked him in the back before hopping away from his clumsy flailing arm.

It was as if Jerome couldn't see her. Jason was bewildered. Only Nadia seemed to see through the essence of what was happening by using her power and causing her eyes to glow blue.

"It's telepathy." Nadia said quietly to Sasha. "Daisy is making Jerome see illusions. She's tricking his brain."

"She's making him look like a doofus." Sasha said, though she wasn't any less starstruck than before. "That just shows how awesome Daisy is!"

Jerome seemed to realize he was being toyed with. He closed his eyes and stopped paying attention to his lying eyes. He listened with his ears, and that allowed him to hear a pair of footsteps quickly approaching from the right.

He slapped his palms against the ground and pounced like a tiger toward those footsteps. He heard Daisy yelp in surprise as she didn't expect him to see through her

deception.

Jerome grinned! He grabbed his opponent- no, he didn't! He grabbed at nothing at all!

It turned out that Daisy hadn't only fooled his eyes, but his ears as well. The spectators watched as he jumped and grabbed at the empty air while Daisy carefully maneuvered herself into the position she had been waiting for.

Jerome opened his eyes, only to see Daisy's foot flying at his chest. He wouldn't be fooled, of course, and instead grabbed behind himself, expected her to teleport there.

But this time, it was the real Daisy! She kicked him backward and sent him tripping off the mat, scoring the first ring-out!

"Point, Daisy!" Jason declared. "It's 1-1 for both combatants."

Jerome was shocked. He had started to realize what she was doing, but in the end he couldn't see through her mental trickery when it mattered.

Jerome stood up and dusted himself off while the small audience cheered for Daisy. He didn't appear mad.

"Your abilities are quite diverse. I'm convinced you're a Trueborn." Jerome said. "But we'll continue to spar until we reach the point cap."

"Playtime is over." Daisy declared. "We've reached the end of my abilities that are useful in the context of a sparring match. My other powers are a lot deadlier, so I won't use them. I only have one left, and... you can't contend with it. So I'll make the next two matches quick."

That seemed to spark Jerome's interest. She had said she was holding back before, but he wasn't sure if that was merely a bluff or not.

"I see. Then show me what you're truly capable of." Jerome said, his expression becoming solemn.

He and Daisy returned to the center of the mat. This time, Daisy didn't even bother taking up a combat stance. She just stood idly while Jason counted down the seconds.

"Three, two, one, fight!" Jason said, making a karate chop motion with his hand.

Jerome started to move toward her, but before he could take two steps, Daisy raised a single finger up.

Jerome lost his footing. He suddenly began to float up into the air and lost contact with the mat. Unable to control himself, he flailed wildly, his eyes filled with shock.

"You-?!"

He didn't get to finish his thought. Daisy pointed her finger downward, and gravity seemed to increase tenfold. Jerome slammed against the mat heavily, knocking the wind out of him. He groaned and tried to stand up, but it was as if an elephant had suddenly sat on his back. His stomach was pinned to the floor, and he could barely lift himself an inch off the ground!

"Rrrgh! Holy- RRRRGH!!!"

Jerome was incredibly strong. His strength increased during times of heightened adrenaline, and with that, he began to shakily lift himself off the mat, but the process was so gradual that he was already starting to fight exhaustion itself.

Sweat dripped from Jerome's forehead. He gasped for air, as Daisy used the power of telekinesis to pin him in place.

He realized now that she wasn't bluffing. She had been able to do this from the start, but had used her lesser abilities instead. Was she doing that to lessen the impact to his psyche, or was she only seeing how far those lesser abilities would take her?

It didn't matter. Ultimately, Jerome's body trembled, and his arms gave out. He collapsed onto his stomach, and Jason began the countdown.

"One! Two! Three! Four! Five! It's a pin! Point, Daisy!"

The telekinetic pressure finally vanished, and Jerome took a long, heavy breath. The crowd cheered for Daisy, and he lifted his head to look at her with deep surprise. He fully believed now that she was a Trueborn.

He envied her.

After a few moments, Jerome stood up and bowed.

"You went easy on me. I concede the next match in advance."

"Sorry." Daisy apologized. "I didn't hurt you, did I?"

She expected Jerome to be at least a little mad at her, but when he raised his head, there was instead a burning passion in his eyes.

"Daisy. I've gotta ask you... that telekinetic power of yours... how long can you maintain it?"

Daisy shrugged. "A long time? Minutes... or maybe hours?"

"My body grows stronger the more pressure it's under. I long ago reached the limits of the Illuminati's mundane training equipment." Jerome said, walking over to her. "If you use your telekinesis on me, I can increase my strength faster than ever! Are you willing to help me?"

Daisy smiled. "Of course! That's why my dad brought you guys here!"

Jason walked over and clapped Jerome on the back. "Good fight, kid. But hold your horses. You might want to wait to hear what I say before you go deciding your future training regimen all on your own."

With that, Jason lined up the dozen new Illuminati recruits and spoke to them with his daughter by his side.

"Everyone, thank you for coming. Earth faces a crisis. As we speak, demons are marching on Mount Sinai to attack the angels. The world you are currently standing on is not Earth, but a secret realm I discovered some time ago with my Archseer powers! This realm has a time dilation of 365 to 1, almost exactly mirroring Earth. Simply put, one day on Earth is one year in here."

He continued. "I have big plans for all of you. I'm going to create custom training regimens for anyone who wants to master their abilities. Additionally, everyone who chooses to stay here will become immortal. No matter how long you spend in Aevum, you'll never worry about growing old and dying! BUT, if you decide you're not up to the task, I'll simply use my powers to wipe your memories and send you back to Earth. We need fighters here, people willing to train hard and fight for the Earth's safety, as well as to protect humanity."

He laid out some more terms, playing the role of the carrot and the stick.

"Now, are you with me?!" Jason shouted.

"Yes, Archseer!" The teenagers replied.

Not one Illuminati trainee chose to return to Earth. The thought of training in a secret dimension was exciting, and as it turned out, Jason generously offered for them to stay in Aevum for a few months and they could leave later if they wanted. Of course, anyone who

left early would have their minds wiped, but that was the price they'd have to pay for this incredible privilege.

After Jason settled them in to their new dorms, he turned to Nadia.

"I should be ready for the operation in a day or two."

"Let's put a pause on that." Nadia retorted. "I studied the footage you gave me. I'm surprised Heaven's Daughter wanted you to blur out her face, but if she wants to keep her identity a secret, that is fine by me. More importantly, I thought of some improvements you could make during the operation process."

Nadia pulled a notebook out of her handbag, which contained several incredibly detailed drawings of her own brain, the MindCore Jason was planning, and some other things.

"See here? If we do this, I believe we can completely eliminate the pain and increase the procedure success rate by 100%. However, this only works on people like me who have not yet developed a Mind Realm. We'll need to develop a different system for people like yourself and Heaven's Daughter, who do have one."

As Jason looked at her mockups, he became more and more surprised.

"That's brilliant! Nadia, you *are* a genius after all."

She blushed. "I'm just cheating with my power."

"Yeah, well, I was an idiot until I became able to cheat with my MindCore. If you're cheating, then I'm hyper-cheating." Jason joked.

He verified a few other things, then nodded his head.

"I'll delay it for a couple more days to iron everything out, but after that, we'll get this operation done."

"I am greatly looking forward to my expanded cognitive abilities." Nadia said with a smile. "I'll be in your care."

With that, the two of them departed.

Jason looked off into the distance.

"Not much longer now." He said to himself. "Once I get these MindCores installed... I can finally act on what I've been wanting to accomplish for nearly a year now..."

Part 706: False Reality

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

A few more days passed inside Aevum. Daisy took time to introduce all the new Illuminati initiates to the full world of Aevum, and their eyes nearly burst out of their heads. They couldn't believe it! How did the Archseer 'find' such an incredible hidden realm on Earth? Where was it even hiding?

Nobody had any idea that Jason had made Aevum himself, nor did they know that it was actually located thousands of lightyears from Earth. They assumed it was a secret dimension hidden somewhere on Earth, similar to Heaven. The fact the legendary Archseer was able to 'find' such a place was quickly forgotten as they started asking bigger questions, like which awe-inspiring precursor species was able to create such a wonderland!

Naturally, when Jason trusted them more, he would tell them the truth. But for now, he had no intention of spreading knowledge of his true capabilities beyond what was necessary. He was also taking great care to monitor all of the dozen Illuminati teenagers for suspicious behavior.

But today, he was not interested in the newcomers. He was putting his full attention on the next operation.

Nadia walked into the operating room and closed the door. Without being asked, she walked over and sat in the operating chair, then smiled at Jason.

"How is it?" She asked.

"I took two days to familiarize myself." Jason said, walking over to stand beside her. "I also made a few minor adjustments, but otherwise if all goes well, this procedure will be no problem at all."

He paused.

"Shall we start?"

Nadia nodded. "I may not seem like it, but I've been anxiously waiting for my upgrade. Every time I've spoken to Heaven's Daughter, I've felt deeply envious of her new capabilities. You should see the amazing things she's already started to do."

Jason hadn't spoken to Catherine in several days. He knew she was doing her best to exploit the potential of the RealitySim, but otherwise, he wasn't informed about the details. He'd been far too busy onboarding the newcomers and preparing the new MindCore installation procedure to keep up to date on important details like these.

"I'll talk to her about it later, before she leaves." Jason said.

"Heaven's Daughter isn't going to stay?" Nadia asked.

Jason shook his head. "Nope. She needs to return to Heaven and help repel the demons. Of course, it's way more time efficient to train with the RealitySim here, but gathering intelligence in the field will allow her to create superior representations of our future enemies inside her simulation cores."

Jason and Nadia exchanged a few more words, but eventually, he put his hand on her forehead.

"Alright. It's time. I'm going to put you to sleep, Nadia. Let's hope your procedure works as planned."

Nadia closed her eyes and waited. Then, Jason spoke a Word of Power.

"**Sleep.**"

Nadia's body became still. Her breathing evened out, and her head fell slightly to the side as she entered a deep coma.

Jason waited a few moments, then used a few Words of Power to monitor her body's vital signs. He created a floating display that showed her heart-rate, brain waves, and other such readouts at a glance, then he began in earnest.

"**Form. Tether. Link.**"

In the air above Nadia's head, Jason summoned an infinitesimally tiny dot of light. It levitated less than an inch from Nadia's glabella, and an even thinner strand of light flowed from this dot to Nadia's soul.

This was her idea: An external Mind Realm made outside of the person's soul which would later be integrated inside!

Jason had thought about creating an external MindCore and placing it directly inside a patient's soul, but it turned out this would not work. If the patient already had a Mind Realm, simply shoving a MindCore in there would cause catastrophic damage and kill

them instantly. If they didn't have a Mind Realm, the MindCore would simply break apart and fragment against their soul, also causing grievous damage.

Thus, the solution came with Nadia's suggestion. What if Jason tethered the person's soul to an externalized Mind Realm, but only through the faintest, weakest link? Then, what if Jason custom-built the MindCore inside this externalized Mind Realm, eventually integrating it back into their soul?

The tether was the key. If he didn't tether their soul at least a tiny bit, the new Mind Realm and MindCore would be rejected by the person's soul. If the link was too strong, then the person would suffer similar, but perhaps lesser agony than Jason endured during his own installation process. And if he made the Mind Realm and MindCore directly inside their soul, well, that simply defeated the point!

Ultimately, the Procedure for Installing MindCores Externally was conceived, or PRIME, for short.

The biggest issue with PRIME was that it wouldn't have worked on Jason or on Catherine, since it required forming a Mind Realm for the first time externally. So long as Jason didn't have to do that in the future, PRIME had no downsides and was strictly a better way of installing MindCores.

Finally, Jason began.

He started by creating the Mind Realm itself, and since Nadia was a Thinker-Hero, Jason decided he would really go all out for her from the start. He took as much power as he could siphon from the local star clusters, passed that energy through Aevum's transference array, and turned it into raw magical energy. Then he began expanding Nadia's Mind Realm to a level far beyond his own.

Unfortunately, Jason's Mind Realm was already solidified. He could improve his MindCore, albeit painfully, but he could not increase the density or size of his Mind Realm. This ultimately wasn't a huge deal for him, as the size of a Mind Realm only really limited what could be stuffed inside of it. Nadia was going to be absorbing an ungodly amount of information thanks to her power, while Jason mainly created blueprints and schematics on the spot. The amount of knowledge he had absorbed from books only appeared inside his Mind Realm as a tiny 'blip' of information.

After all, storing a bunch of books on a computer took very little storage space compared to images, videos, songs, and other highly complex media. Since Nadia would

be storing the full comprehension of anything she learned, that would be tens of times more space-intensive than the methods Jason used.

As such, he first inflated her Mind Realm to the biggest size he could muster. It ended up being three times the size of his own. He created several minor components that would allow it to increase further in the future depending on her needs, assuming her spirituality increased further, then he focused on making her Mind Realm more 'dense'.

When Jason had first inflated it, it had ended up like a balloon blown up to its maximum size. It was extremely fragile, and a focused telepathic attack could have caused her serious damage. But now, he reinforced Nadia's new Mind Realm as much as possible, turning it into an armored fortress.

Nobody, not even the Second Founder, would ever be able to read her thoughts.

With the basic foundation laid, Jason slowly began constructing an internal world even bigger than the one he had made for Catherine. With greater size came greater raw computational power. As a mortal human, Nadia had far less mana at her disposal, but so long as she lived inside Aevum, she would be able to channel its raw power inside her mind to speed up her mental simulations. Back on Earth, those simulations would be much slower, and the throughput would be less significant, but barring any external factors, she would actually have a higher quality of magical energy at her disposal than even Jason himself.

He had to admit... he was jealous. Nobody had shown him this much care when he started out. The Wordsmith had fumbled around for years, decades, centuries, all while tripping over one roadblock after another.

His Mind Realm's foundation was much crappier than Nadia's. But even so, he was determined to pull out all the stops for her.

"You know, Nadia..." Jason said quietly to the unconscious girl. "I'd love it if you decided to stay in Aevum and help me make it fantastic. But I won't force you. You'll want to go home eventually, and it wouldn't be right for me to take that from you."

He paused to tap his chin.

"Now that I think about it though... is this really the limit of a Mind Realm? Is this all I can do with one? Just make people smarter in different ways? It's not bad, but... I feel like I could do more."

Jason thought about it, but he didn't want to drag out the surgery for too long. He resumed work and started building similar Titan-based architecture, magical arrays, and other such constructs and artifacts all around Nadia's Mind Realm. He chuckled quietly, wondering if Catherine would be jealous of Nadia once she saw how much better Nadia's MindCore was turning out.

But hey, it wasn't Jason's fault. If Catherine hadn't possessed a Mind Realm already, he would have been able to make hers just as good, perhaps even better than Nadia's. Jason had no doubt that the sister of a Trueborn Hero probably had an incredible seed of innate talent. That was why Raphael poached her, after all.

Mind Realms were reality-breaking creations. They encompassed a Sentient's thoughts, dreams, and imagination. They were a microscopic bubble of energy invisible to mundane technology, but they contained an entire microscopic world full of possibility within them. Until the invention of MindCores, Jason imagined all Mind Realms were pretty barren and underutilized.

But that thought gave him pause.

Was this assumption… true?

What about Raphael, Unarin, or Solomon? What about Camael? Could certain legendary Thinkers like them have found a way to uplift the potential of their Mind Realms?

Short of asking them if he could take a peep, Jason wasn't sure.

He shrugged and continued.

Three hours passed. Now that he didn't have to worry about causing his patient pain, Jason was able to Wordsmith nonstop and get the operation done as quickly as possible. He finished up, then stared at the tiny speck of light hovering above Nadia's glabella.

With a wave of his hand, Jason pushed the light into her skull. He held his breath and waited as the Mind Realm began to sprout tendrils inside her head, attaching itself to her soul and brain, forming a link between the two.

A moment later, Nadia's eyes snapped open.

She awakened instantly, without Jason even needing to rouse her. The power of her MindCore was so insane that she instantly overwrote his Word of Power and seized control of her body.

But Nadia did not move. She simply stared up at the ceiling, unblinking.

"Nadia? Nadia, are you okay?" Jason asked.

Jason waved his hand over Nadia's face, but she didn't even twitch an eye. She had no reaction to him whatsoever.

Jason's heart skipped a beat. Had he screwed up?!

He suddenly felt a jolt of ice rush through his veins. He began to fear the worst, as waves of guilt started building up in his heart. The face of Phoebe flashed in front of his eyes, and he took a long, shuddering breath.

"N-Nadia? Come on, honey... **Awaken!**"

Jason's hands trembled. He locked his gaze onto her own, waiting for a response!

And then, finally, she blinked her eyes.

Nadia's eyes relaxed. She looked to the left, then the right.

"I'm awake?" Nadia asked.

"Yes." Jason said. "Are you okay? Do you need water or anything?"

Nadia blinked a few more times. She sat up in the operating chair, then climbed out of it. She began turning in place, looking all around the room.

"Am I awake?" Nadia asked again, before lowering her eyes and noticing Jason for the first time. "Are you... real?"

Jason quickly nodded. He walked over and gently grabbed her shoulders. "It's me, Jason. Are you okay, Nadia?"

Nadia squinted slightly. She raised a hand... and then she touched Jason's face.

"Am I awake?" Nadia asked again. "Are you real?"

Something was wrong. Jason couldn't tell exactly what, but she almost seemed to be in a state of shock.

"Nadia, you're really awake." Jason repeated.

"...But you've said that before." Nadia said, squinting to look at him carefully. "Am I completely awake? This isn't... another simulation?"

Jason stared at her. "Another simulation? What do you mean?"

She stared back. "What do you mean... 'what do I mean'?"

Nadia pulled away from his grasp. She took a few steps backward and then turned to walk around the room, examining it carefully.

"No... I can't tell. It seems the same as last time." Nadia said to herself, her voice low. "Did I get it wrong again?"

She walked over to the door leading outside, then she opened it up. Jason followed her as she stepped into the hospital medical storage area, which in turn led outside to outer Aevum.

"Dammit!" Nadia suddenly shouted, making Jason jump. "It's the same! Another fucking simulation! How long has it been?! How many times am I going to experience this fucking day again?!"

At that moment, Jason's heart fell. He realized what had happened.

Through some sort of unknown circumstance, Nadia had been trapped inside the RealitySim for an unknown period of time. She had tried to turn it off and return to reality, but must have somehow kept simulating the same events over and over and over again.

The power of her MindCore was terrifying. If it hadn't been calibrated before she used it, she might have lived at 10,000 times Aevum's speed, causing her to live days, weeks, years, or even centuries, unable to escape.

Jason quickly walked over and grabbed Nadia's shoulder.

"Nadia! You've escaped! You've REALLY escaped! It's me, Jason!"

He tried to spin Nadia around, but she quickly pulled away from his grasp and gave him a look of disgust.

"God, would you shut up already?! Always the same nagging shit!" Nadia spat. "Again and again and again! What next, you're going to use your magic to convince me? Teleport me to Earth and show me around? I'm sick of this! I'd rather die than be stuck in here any longer! Just let me die! LET ME FUCKING DIE!!"

Tears welled up in Nadia's eyes. She didn't even bother to wipe them away. She simply turned and stormed out of the room, shrieking in rage at everyone and everything around her.

* * *

Jason didn't know what to do. By no means did he blame Nadia for her outburst. She genuinely couldn't tell reality from fiction. If this was happening to anyone else, he would ask Nadia for help on fixing the situation... but the one in need of help was Nadia herself!

Nadia charged into the residential compound. She threw the door open and startled Daisy, who hadn't sensed her approach. Thanks to Nadia's new MindCore, her cerebral presence had been completely masked from telepaths.

"Nadia?" Daisy asked, uncertainly. "Are you-"

"FUCK OFF!!" Nadia shouted, causing Marco and Sasha, sitting on a couch across the room, to jerk in surprise.

Nadia was a prim and proper girl. Somewhat shy. She had never had an outburst like this before. Everyone knew she was going into the operation room, but they didn't expect her to return enraged as if her entire family had been murdered.

Jason quickly entered after her. He saw the looks on everyone's faces and knew Nadia had gone off the rails.

"It's not Nadia's fault!" Jason explained. "I think she was trapped in the RealitySim and-"

"And I keep living the same day over and over and OVER!!" Nadia shouted, spinning to scream at Jason. "This is all your fault! I hate you! I fucking HATE you, do you hear me?! If I ever escape this mental torture, I'm going to kill you myself! GOD! I'm so sick of hearing you say the same thing every single time!!"

Nadia's eyes darted toward the kitchen. She stormed inside and grabbed a giant knife, then charged at Jason with bloodlust and deadly intent.

"Nadia, Nadia I'm real! I'm REAL!" Jason exclaimed. "Put the knife down!"

"I fucking **hope** you're real!" Nadia spat back. "That way I can kill you for what you've done to me! You worthless piece of shit!"

She tried to stab him, but naturally, her pitiful strength didn't amount to much.

"**Restrain!**" Jason shouted.

With a single Word of Power, he bound Nadia in place. Her rage turned to fear. Her body trembled as he took a step toward her.

"No! NO! Please! Please don't do it again! Stop! STOP!! I don't wanna start over! I DON'T WANNA START OVER!!"

Jason paused. He obviously wasn't planning to hurt Nadia, but something had been seriously irking him since she woke up.

Just how well did her MindCore predict what was going to happen?! It was as if she had somehow predicted every scenario or thing Jason would say while reliving the day over and over again.

That meant, from her perspective, something kept happening in her predictions that 'reset' the day. Did she kill Jason, causing the day to reset? Did he kill her? Did it end when she fell asleep? Perhaps all of those scenarios, and many more?

Jason carefully walked toward Nadia. She wriggled and writhed, acting as if he were a specter of doom coming to kill her. But then, he he drew close enough, Jason gently held out his palms and touched her face.

"Nadia." Jason said quietly. "I know you think I'm a simulation, okay? I'm not. Please, calm down for a moment, and explain to me what events cause your day to reset."

Nadia started to cry. She was clearly petrified out of her wits, afraid never seeing a future she so desperately wished to experience again.

"You... you... please..." Nadia blubbered. "Please don't kill me... let me wake up... please, please, I'm begging you..."

"Nadia." Jason said quietly. "If you make it to the end of today, and the day doesn't reset, will that convince you you're out of the simulation?"

Nadia closed her eyes. She sobbed quietly, her shoulders trembling.

"You... you've said that... so many times..." Nadia whimpered. "Let me go... please..."

Daisy walked over. Seeing his daughter arrive, Jason released Nadia and took the knife away from her. She broke down crying in Daisy's arms, and Jason left the room.

Naturally, the next morning, Nadia realized that she had broken the cycle. She was back in reality.

But Nadia was not the same person anymore. Her mental torture had instantly changed her from a bright-eyed schoolgirl to a broken mess who constantly doubted her reality.

Even with Nadia having realized she escaped the simulation, she was not fully convinced. She constantly questioned if this was just another level of torture.

As for Jason, he sat inside his Sanctum, a dark cloud hanging over his head.

He had screwed up again. He made her MindCore too powerful and accidentally tortured a young woman for potentially years or longer. He still had no idea how long Nadia had been stuck inside her own head.

"I'm a failure." Jason mumbled to himself. "Always have been. Always will be. Why am I even trying?"

The future of his MindCore projects were now in flux. The guilt he felt laid upon his back like a blue whale, making him feel burdened beyond his own mental limits.

He was no longer certain of what path he should take.

Part 707: A Woman Now

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

The next morning, Jason approached his father. Hideki was lounging on the couch again, watching the final episode of some sitcom from the 70's.

"Dad-" Jason started to say, but Hideki quickly raised a hand.

"No. Go away. The kid'll be fine."

"Have we had this conversation bef-"

"Yup."

Hideki cut his son off without explanation, frustrating Jason immensely. The guilt he felt for what he'd done to Nadia was overwhelming. What did his dad mean by 'she would be okay'? What constituted 'okay'? Because it sure looked like Jason had left Nadia traumatized and fearful.

Just as Jason was about to leave, Hideki turned his eyes to look at Jason, then he spoke up. "Since I'm about to finish this show, I'll only say this once. Son, right now we're on my first loop. Once I see how everything pans out, I might rewind all or some of the way back to the beginning, the day when you locked me in to this new timeline."

"Your first loop?" Jason asked.

"That's right. Any time I reach the end of my natural life, or the end of what used to be the 'end goal', ie; the destruction of Earth, once I rewound all the way back to the beginning, that was *one* loop. We're still on my first one. I'm currently seeing how everything pans out before I decide whether to go back or not."

Jason stared at his father. "Are you saying you might *not* rewind time at the end?"

Hideki sighed.

"Jason. I spent so much time trying to save the Earth, and I sort of failed, but then I succeeded when you rewound. I don't want to do all that crap again from the start. I'm tired. I just want to watch my granddaughter grow up, see how things turn out, and then make my decision at the end. If you end up saving the Earth, albeit imperfectly, I'll just leave it like that. I'm not going to bother trying to save everyone. There's going to be

losses, people suffering major ill effects, and so on. If it takes a couple of loops to figure out a few key details that will allow you to save humanity, then so be it."

Hideki closed his eyes.

"But I'm done with perfection. I'm aiming for 'good enough' and don't you even bother trying to motivate me beyond that. Don't come running to me, wanting me to fix fuckups on your end. Unless you or Daisy ends up dying, I don't care who else does."

Jason pursed his lips. "But Nadia is just a kid, dad."

"So? Everyone is just a kid at some point. She'll be an adult someday. Depending on how you grade things, spending seventy three years in that simulation technically makes her an old woman. Mentally, at the least."

Jason hadn't told his dad how long Nadia had been in the time loop. Not this rewind, anyway. He must have done so in a previous one. Jason was getting used to his dad knowing stuff Jason was about to tell him.

For some reason, Hideki's words made Jason feel a little better. He wasn't sure why, but Hideki's logic seemed to make Jason's nerves ease up a little bit.

"I see. Thanks, dad." Jason muttered, before turning away.

After Jason left, Hideki clicked play on his sitcom and went back to consuming the content.

* * *

Some time later, Jason entered the dormitories. He walked over to the female half, then paused outside for a long time.

Jason hung his head. He wanted to knock, to go inside, to see how Nadia was doing.

But he didn't feel that he deserved to know. He had screwed her up. He had ruined her life and locked her inside a simulation for 73 years.

She was a teenager when she entered. With no real social contact, she had been living with fake people for what felt like tens of real years. Her RealitySim had been supercharged to such a level that it had spun up way outside of anyone's expectations. Jason hadn't taken more than ten to fifteen seconds to wake her up after attaching the MindCore to her Mind Realm, but those seconds ended up becoming a lifetime's worth of trauma.

Suddenly, the door opened, startling Jason. Daisy stood in the doorway.

"Dad..." Daisy said, noticing the poorly concealed pain on his face. "Come in. Nadia's been waiting for you."

"She has?" Jason asked. "That's hard to believe."

Daisy sighed. She gestured inside, and Jason followed her.

When he entered, Jason was surprised to see Nadia and Sasha sitting at a small table. Nadia calmly sipped some tea. She smiled when Jason walked over.

"Hey." Jason said.

"Hey." Nadia replied.

A moment of hesitation later, Nadia carefully motioned with her hand to the chair on her right. Jason chose to sit on the opposite side of the table. When he sat, Sasha and Daisy left the room, allowing Jason and Nadia to remain together, alone. This was outside his expectations.

"I'm... I'm so sorry." Jason said quietly. "I don't even know what to say, or where to begin."

"A lot has happened." Nadia said softly. "Jason, I'm sorry too.. I said some... some really terrible things. I didn't know this was reality. I thought I was still in the simulation."

"I know." Jason answered. "But it's only natural you'd hate me so much after what I did to you. Don't pretend you were making things up just so you won't hurt my feelings now. I deserve your hatred."

Nadia shook her head.

"Jason, you really don't know me that well. The others do. I realized I was trapped in a simulation within the first week. You know how my powers work. I am able to comprehend things extremely well, and my powers worked just fine inside my Mind Realm."

Nadia licked her lips thoughtfully.

"I immediately realized something had gone wrong with the surgery. I first hallucinated exiting surgery and talking to you about how things had gone. Everything

seemed to have ended well, but at the end of the day, time rewound, and I woke up back in the surgery room."

She continued. "For a short time, I thought I might have somehow started rewinding time like Hideki. But I deduced that was extremely unlikely, and since my new MindCore was all about simulations, I started feeling afraid that I was trapped in a coma. I didn't know that my MindCore had drastically accelerated my perception of time."

Jason looked at her in surprise. "So your anger wasn't that you had been trapped..."

"Not at all. I started to think that every second spent in the false reality meant a second had passed in realspace. I thought I was trapped there with reality passing me by. I thought that if I was there long enough, all my real friends would grow old and die, or leave me behind in an unknown future."

"I spent the first several years trying to break the loop. I never succeeded." Nadia explained. "But then I found out that I could change what was being simulated by conversing with the other characters. It's a little hard to explain, but for some reason, I didn't possess 'administrator rights' over my MindCore. *You* did. Well, your character in my dream, at least. Except your character kept treating me like a stupid little girl who didn't know the difference between my head and my toes, so I had to find ways to convince him to alter the parameters of the looping reality."

Jason listened quietly. He was surprised by Nadia's calmness, but now he understood why.

It was because after waking up, Nadia realized that no time had passed at all in the outside world. She hadn't been idly wasting her time away inside the simulation, but had previously been terrified and angry, thinking her friends would have moved on without her, or Earth might have fallen, or some other horrid circumstance might have come to pass! Instead, everything was okay, and her fears had ultimately proven unfounded.

"What sort of alterations did you make?" Jason asked.

"Well, I found out that the character of Jason in my simulation actually seemed to have all your knowledge." Nadia said. "So I had him teach me about the events of the future, and tell me everything he knew. Um. Well, I'm uh... I'm sorry to say this... but I know all about your Wordsmithing now. All the, um, secret details you haven't told anyone else."

Nadia looked away sheepishly, while Jason's pupils shrunk to pinpricks. His heart nearly stopped on the spot!

"H-how?!" Jason gasped. "How would the simulated version of myself..."

He paused. Then it dawned on him.

"It's because... when I made your MindCore, I *really* poured my power into making your Mind Realm. It must have linked up my memories and placed them inside your Mind Realm."

Nadia nodded in embarrassment. "I wouldn't have pressured 'him' so much, but I was desperate to escape. I thought if I unraveled your abilities, I might find a loophole I could exploit to wake myself up."

Jason relaxed a little.

"It's fine, Nadia. I don't mind that you know. It's probably better if you do. I could use a smart person who knows my abilities on my side. If you don't hate me, that is."

Nadia smiled shyly. "Well, the simulations of everyone else were quite... crude. It became clear to me that the others were only, um, shallow recreations of their living selves. Only you felt real and genuine."

She crossed her arms and then looked away. "But anyway, um, so yeah. I started simulating the future events you knew and learned all kinds of crazy stuff. It seems your plans for the future go deeper than anyone here knows. I only yelled at you out of frustration, but I didn't mean any of those awful things I said. I'm sorry, Jason. I'm really sorry."

"I'm sorry too." Jason said, pressing his face into his palm. "I've only ever felt as awful as when you woke up and started screaming maybe two or three other times in my life."

Nadia looked at him. She seemed as if she wanted to say something, but then she decided not to.

Even Jason had no idea just how many of his rawest memories Nadia had seen and lived.

"I simulated a lot of things." Nadia said, changing the subject somewhat. "With your- I mean, Mind-Jason's help, I was able to create a simulation of Volgarius and explore it. I traveled around inside the future Labyrinth. I tried building new technology, but all my progress kept getting reset at the end of each 24 hour period. Also, sometimes Mind-

Jason wouldn't work with me, and that happened around 40% of the time, so I ended up wasting a lot of days."

"Well, at least you didn't seem to go insane." Jason said. "...Right? Are you doing okay, mentally?"

"I think I'm okay." Nadia said softly. "But I'm still, *still* not entirely sure if this is the real world. I keep thinking I'll wake up back on that operating chair. If I do, I might truly break this time..."

Sometimes, it was worse for someone who was suffering to experience a moment of pure joy and hope, especially if it was only going to be snuffed out by the same darkness as before. Luckily, Jason knew she had truly woken up. She was going to be okay.

"You said you don't have admin access." Jason pointed out. "Maybe I can fine-tune your RealitySim's settings?"

"Please do." Nadia immediately agreed. "I don't know if I'll fall asleep again and get locked into a new loop for an entire night. Based on what I've heard, I was only under the loop for fifteen Aevum-seconds. If it were an entire night, then..."

Jason swallowed heavily. She didn't say the last part, but he knew what she meant. It would probably end up feeling like hundreds of thousands, or perhaps even millions of years. The compounding effect of Aevum's time acceleration could apparently prove disastrous when paired with an overclocked MindCore.

Jason carefully stood up, then walked around the table to stand behind Nadia. When he reached out and touched both sides of Nadia's head, he felt her body tense up.

It didn't feel as if she were scared of his touch, but rather... something else. He couldn't put his finger on it.

Jason closed his eyes. He uttered a few Words of Power and identified the issues that had locked up her MindCore, then told her how to fix the issue. After making some crucial adjustments herself, Nadia finally obtained administrator rights, and she relaxed a little.

Jason started to walk back to the other side of the table, but he paused and instead sat in the chair on her right, like she had indicated earlier.

"Can you try activating a simulation again?" Jason asked.

Nadia didn't move. She shook slightly, becoming visibly fearful of the suggestion.

"I... I don't know if... if I can..." Nadia said softly.

"I'll be here with you this time." Jason said. "I won't let your MindCore trap you again."

Nadia looked at him with trusting eyes. She silently nodded, then Jason uttered a Word of Power.

His soul separated from his body, and he dove into her glabella. He helped her create a new simulation inside of her RealitySim, one which was small enough in scale that it would allow her to re-acclimate to properly simulating reality, yet big enough that it could feel substantial.

They decided to simulate Nadia's bedroom back on Earth. When they arrived, Nadia paused to look around.

"It's so... childish..." She muttered, before blushing in embarrassment. "I'm sorry. I haven't seen my room in a long time. This isn't who I am anymore..."

Jason glanced at the walls. Her room was mostly clean and tidy, but there were lots of posters of Russian techno boy bands, with young and hunky heartthrobs. Her shelves had figurines of various idols, and other stuff that marked her as a teenage girl.

"I didn't know you were into stuff like this." Jason commented idly.

Nadia shrugged. She picked up a figurine off the table. "I'm not. Not anymore. This is all from my childhood."

Jason's stomach sank. He stared at Nadia, wordless, for a few moments.

It was at this moment that it really hit him. She was just like him now. A fully matured adult, trapped in the body of a teenager. She had long grown out of so many things she enjoyed as a teenager that looking back at her room was totally alienating.

Sure, she had spent seventy-three years inside the same looping day, but there was no chance she hadn't grown up and matured at least a little. Especially with the MindCore drastically empowering her intelligence.

Nadia bit her lower lip. She gave Jason a strange look, with eyes that contained a mystery he didn't quite understand.

"I don't know how I'm going to face them." Nadia said.

"W-who?" Jason asked.

"Everyone." Nadia said, lowering her eyes. She fiddled with the figurine absentmindedly. "My mother and father. My friends out there. For you all, I went into an operating room one day ago. But for me, I've been out of contact with Daisy, Marco, and Sasha for seven decades. I stopped enjoying talking to their simulated selves a long time ago."

"Well... what do you like to do now, then?" Jason asked.

Nadia didn't look up from the floor.

"I... I like..."

She fell silent, unable to meet his gaze.

"...you were always there for me." Nadia said, after several moments of quiet. "You showed me a fantastical future. A world of aliens, and demons, angels, monsters. You showed me the galaxy. You entertained me, comforted me when I was on the verge of mentally breaking... you were the only one who was always there. The other simulated people were simply... hollow."

Jason felt his blood go cold. When Nadia looked at him, he finally recognized the look in her eyes.

It wasn't a bad look. It was, by all accounts, a deep sense of love and adoration. It was the look of a woman who had found her soulmate.

But there was just one problem.

"That... wasn't..." Jason started to say.

"It wasn't you. I know." Nadia said quietly. "It was your simulated self. And he reset every day. He reverted back to the you of now. I grew to love him more and more, to the point it hurt my heart when I remembered precious, shared memories which he never could."

"Nadia." Jason said, his tone even. "I'm truly sorry. What I've done to you is... it's unfair. It's really, really unfair."

"You don't love me back." Nadia said.

It wasn't a question. It was a statement, one confirmed by decades of knowledge.

"I already know." Nadia said, sighing to herself. She turned her head to look out the window at the simulated neighborhood outside of her house. The sun shone down on the

flower gardens, vehicles parked in driveways, and dogs roaming around in their yards.

Jason's expression fell.

He didn't know what to do.

When he failed to speak, Nadia intervened. "You love your wife, Phoebe. Your simulated self spoke about her often. He even made me feel jealous with how much he loved her. I wished he would love me that much. Since I couldn't forge any permanent bonds with him... since he always forgot our shared experiences... our relationship never developed further. Perhaps it was for the better. He was only a fantasy, after all. But for seventy-three years, he didn't feel like one."

Jason massaged his elbow. He looked out the window as well, feeling deeply uncomfortable with the direction of the conversation, clueless as to what to say, and at a loss for what to do.

"You have to delete that... that fake Jason." Jason said. "You had no choice but to love him, or risk psychosis from loneliness. He's not real, though. He's just a delusion."

"You know, he said the same thing many times when I told him I loved him." Nadia said. "I cried a lot. Too many times. He never once looked at me as a woman. But I didn't care, because I prayed I would break free someday."

Nadia swallowed heavily.

"I love you, Jason." She said, turning to look at him. "I love you so much that I don't want you to force yourself to love me back. I know you feel deeply guilty about what happened to me. But you shouldn't. You should find Phoebe and save her. Don't hesitate or second guess your feelings just because of me. I'll stay here on the sidelines, hoping, praying, pining like a fool to see if you ever have room in your heart for me."

"I know it's hard." Jason said, uneasily meeting her gaze. "But you should try to move on."

"Oh, don't worry. I will." Nadia promised. "But right now, my biggest fear is that... after hearing everything I've said, you'll push me away. You won't force me to leave, will you?"

Jason immediately shook his head. "No! Of course not. If you want to stay in Aevum, you can. If you want to leave, you can. I owe you that much."

"Thank you, Jason." Nadia said, smiling beautifully. "I knew you'd say that... but I still had doubts. It seems I haven't learned any self-confidence after seventy-three years."

She paused. The room became quiet.

Nadia looked away. "You should go. I want to stay here for a while, by myself. I need to sort some things out."

Jason nodded. "Yeah. Of course. I'll go. If you aren't awake within sixty seconds, I'll check to make sure you're not trapped again."

"That won't be necessary. I have full control now." Nadia promised.

After exchanging a few more words, Jason silently withdrew, leaving Nadia alone. His soul departed from her Mind Realm, and she was once again alone.

She stood in the bedroom she'd lived in when she was a teenager, feeling like an old woman who stepped through a time machine.

"This isn't who I am anymore." Nadia said.

With a wave of her hand, she fragmented the reality and destroyed it, instead conjuring a bedroom that seemed much more modern, inside an apartment building inside New York City.

The sights outside were jaw-dropping. Nadia looked out the window at Central Park, where featureless, faceless human blobs milled around in the distance.

"It's fine if the 'real' Jason doesn't love me." Nadia said. "Because I have *you*."

She waved her hand. Jason reappeared in front of her.

But this was not the real Jason. He was the simulation of his downloaded memories.

Nadia touched his head, altering his cerebral parameters. This was now effortless for her, after she had finally unlocked full control over her MindCore.

"Forget about Phoebe now." Nadia said quietly, rewriting the false Jason's memories. "But no need to force things."

She paused.

"Why don't we... get to know each other properly this time?"

'Jason' smiled.

"You look a little young for me, but I wouldn't mind getting to know you better." He said.

Part 708: Sarabiya

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Jason sat inside his Sanctum yet again, his legs crossed, his elbows on his knees, his hands folded together, and his head bowed in thought. It was a pose he had become familiar with over the last year or so he'd spent in Aevum.

Yesterday, when he assumed this pose, it was because he was feeling deep guilt and a sense of failure so profound it bordered on the suicidal.

Today, he felt better. But not by much.

After speaking to Nadia and learning the truth of her situation, Jason didn't feel like he had gotten lucky. He had still badly traumatized the young girl. Things may have turned out better than expected, but they had not turned out well.

He thought for a long while about the next steps in his grand plan.

He decided he didn't like the way that plan was going.

"I want to see my wife again." Jason mumbled to the void.

It was his heart's deepest desire. It was a hunger that overwhelmed even the pain of her loss. It was the single strand of hope he was holding on to, hoping it would help him overcome the agony he had suffered when he held her body in his arms.

In truth, he knew the possibility this would make him whole again was essentially zero. He was too broken now. The pieces could not be put back together.

But... even if it was no longer possible, he still had the selfish wish to see her smiling face one more time.

"Daisy wants to see her mom too." Jason reminded himself.

This Phoebe wasn't his wife, nor was she Daisy's mom. She was her younger self who didn't know either of them.

But to the Jason of now, that did not matter.

Jason slowly stood up. He stretched his limbs and cracked his back. His body shivered as the blood rushed into his dormant muscles, feeling both painful and pleasurous.

Then, uttering a Word of Power, he disappeared.

Deep inside the deserts of south western Egypt, within an environment seemingly inhospitable to most lifeforms, there existed a secret area hidden by a formation made from fairy magic. This formation was massive, more than five miles in diameter, hidden deep within the Sahara's oppressive heat.

It was no ordinary formation. It used the constant, year-round solar energy to generate enough energy to power a protective force field that cooled its interior to a pleasant level of heat. Inside the barrier, a civilized oasis had formed thousands of years prior, when humanity was still in its infancy, and Egypt had been the powerhouse of the world.

This land was known as Sarabiya; *The Illusory City*.

Few knew how to find it, and none of them were mortal humans. For all their modern military power and cerebral conceit, the humans of the 21st century had yet to exhaustively scour the deserts for such a land. Since almost nobody knew it existed, they wouldn't bother to look for it when thousands of planes had flown over the desert since the early 1900s.

The only entrance to the city of Sarabiya was the Pylon of Whispers, a giant trapezoidal gate where the illusory formation could be raised and lowered at will. The gate itself was large but benign, with murals carved into its face of beautiful women, handsome men, and children playing gaily, all to seduce the minds of any wanderers lost in the desert who might fall prey to the Sphinx's machinations.

The entire layout of Sarabiya centered around the Citadel of the Sphinx, a massive fortress with an open roof where Bahamut could take to the throne atop the citadel and project her voice across the city, commanding her thralls to do as she wished. The Citadel itself was seemingly made of gold bricks, but in actuality they were bricks of compacted sand, tinted using magic from the demons to give her citadel a blinding brilliance under the midday sun. Though the Sahara's heat might not penetrate its barrier, its sun was just as bright as anywhere else, and thus the Sphinx's Citadel would hurt the eyes of any who gazed upon its beauty for too long.

The citadel itself was designed to resemble a modified Pyramid, but one that had more of an Incan design than the ones found across Egypt. It was formed with giant steps that led upward to the open-domed roof, allowing her servants to approach from any direction

and bow before their queen. Its unique design was due to the efforts of a demonic builder who had put his own touch on it, much to Bahamut's delight. She very much enjoyed owning one-of-a-kind wonders that nobody else did.

It was on a random Friday in January when the entrance to Sarabiya flickered. A demon envoy appeared and knelt outside on one knee as he activated the formation magic and awaited Bahamut's response.

Bahamut, the leader of this city, had ruled without restraint since her awakening as the Sphinx after obtaining the power from her predecessor, Jarnof. Thousands had entered her gates over the years, and few had left. She rarely had guests, but those she allowed were either powerful demons, or envoys of said demons.

Thus, the veil of illusion flickered, and a monster stepped outside. This monster was quite grotesque, large, and brutish. It had pure black skin with golden engravings upon its body. It was completely nude, wielding a single demonstone polearm that could deal massive damage to anyone it sought to destroy.

"**State your name.**" The lone guard said, its gravelly voice hideous and frightening.

The demon raised his head. "I am Dagon, Baron of Filth, vassal to Emperor Auger. I come to deliver news from the east."

The guardsman slowly looked Dagon's body up and down. Dagon was a hideous demon, with rotted teeth and a smile that could make a man vomit on the spot. He wore black robes that did little to stifle the desert's heat, but as a demon he didn't care about temperatures like these. He was used to worse.

"**Proceed.**" The guard replied.

Dagon nodded. He rose, then entered the city, walking down its streets with speed and purpose.

Sarabiya was not an ordinary city. Its residents were mindless monsters controlled completely by Bahamut, and as such they did not live like any other creatures in the Milky Way.

They still needed to eat food, so some were designated as farmers and forced to toil endlessly during the day. The grain they farmed was made into simple, flavorless meals intended only for the thralls. Bahamut herself ate delicacies imported from all around the world.

The slaves still needed to sleep, so they all went to bed at the same time, save for Bahamut's harem, who worked in shifts to please their sleepless master.

The slaves did not require socialization, or have any desires. Thus, they all lived in plain, boring, bland abodes with limited facilities. Their lives would be considered bleak to any outside observers, worse than the living conditions of many third world human nations.

But they were mindless. Their true selves slept, unaware of the passage of time.

Thus, as Dagon quickly moved down the streets, he forced himself to ignore the silence. It was as if he were walking through a dead city, one whose people had all perished thousands of years ago. There was no chatter in the streets, no vendors selling food, no children running around and playing, nothing to indicate tens of thousands of people lived here.

He passed by beautiful, empty courtyards. Not intended for the people, but for Bahamut's amusement alone. She frequently had these marvels ripped down and rebuilt in fresh forms to amuse herself. As a result, long lost structures that may have once qualified as 'ancient world wonders' had been lost to memory.

Dagon approached the Sphinx's Citadel. He had come here many times, but even so, he sighed with envy as he looked up at the towering golden pyramid. Its beauty stole the wind from his lungs. He paused for a moment to gaze upon its splendor, then he walked inside through one of the four grand entrances at the bottom.

The outside of the Citadel was always brilliantly bright. The Egyptian sun made one's eyes sting, but the interior of the Citadel had no windows at all. Once he entered, the light behind him quickly disappeared. By the time he'd rounded a few corners, Dagon had entered a new world illuminated by flickering torches ensconced along the walls.

Instead of the seductive murals outside, the inner walls were covered in detailed, low-relief carvings that depicted Bahamut's victories over various mythical creatures and heroes... always culminating in the moment of her captives' binding. These were not glorious battle scenes, but moments of subtle, inevitable defeat, often showing her subjects frozen mid-riddle.

How many men and women had become ensnared over the years? None knew, not even Bahamut herself. Even though their bodies had been enslaved, sometimes she got a kick of out torturing one of her subjects to death, or just killing someone if she was in a

bad mood. She certainly didn't care about some random human slave's death. She could acquire others with ease.

The floors of her Citadel were a mosaic of polished obsidian and white marble arranged in intricate geometric patterns that often resolved into the abstract shaped of coiled serpents, predatory eyes, or otherworldly creatures she had seen in her dreams. The mosaics were always kept polished and immaculate by her harem.

Before long, Dagon passed the first harem chamber. He stopped and grinned as he looked upon the otherworldly beauty of female slaves bathing together, washing their bodies, their seductive figures tantalizingly close, yet punishable by death if a guest like himself were to touch.

These women were sometimes not women at all. Bahamut's magic could change the forms of her slaves. She could turn humans into monsters, and monsters into humans. Demons were counted among her slaves, tacitly allowed by demonkind's rulers as long as they were weak, useless peons. No Emperor cared if a few hundred useless grunts went missing.

Thus, if the true figures of these beautiful women were to be revealed, their actual beauty would surely diminish, and some might prove to have originally been men! The same was true of her male harem members, some of whom might have originally been women. Bahamut considered the changing of her harem's forms to be a sort of torture in and of itself.

Bahamut had two types of slaves. The first were her thralls who had no need to speak, and no need to look beautiful as they merely worked the mines beneath the city. The second group were members of her harem, whom she could be quite capricious with. She made sure these slaves were only the finest and most beautiful or handsome individuals she could forge. Each one tickled her fancy in a slightly different way. Who knew how many she had assaulted over the eons? Her sexual appetite was voracious. She loved to exert her will over defenseless people more than anything else.

Dagon stared into the room of beauties for a long moment, feeling his loins heat up. He often wished someone would take out Bahamut so he and the other demons could force themselves upon her harem, but even he had no idea that their appearances were entirely artificial. Without Bahamut around, they would return to their original forms.

If Bahamut were a demon, her title would likely have been *Emperor of Lies*.

Dagon eventually swallowed heavily. He continued deeper into the citadel, proceeding deep underground. Eventually, through the silence of the citadel's lonely halls, he heard a woman's laughter. It was not pleasant, but rather vicious and cruel.

"Hee! Look at you, imbecile! That is what you get for spilling my precious wine! You have but one job, yet you cannot do even that much! Tell me, are you useless or not, HEE?!"

Dagon rounded the corner. He paused when he entered a grand chamber where he saw Bahamut laying on her side atop a gold and red couch, slaves bowing before her. Bahamut sipped wine from a comically ostentatious golden goblet, chirping as her tongue flicked from her beak to dab at the liquid.

In the center of the room, there was a beautiful female slave lashed to a table, her arms and legs outstretched in all directions, violently yanked apart by shackles. The table was a torture device intended to eventually rip the limbs off its victims by slowly pulling them apart. A cruel and heinous method of torture, and one that Bahamut reveled in.

Bahamut's slaves were usually compelled into mindless silence by her magic. But on this day, the woman lashed to the table was shivering and crying, her body in absolute agony. Bahamut had deliberately removed the mental suppression, delighting in the woman's pained whimpers and begging for forgiveness.

"Please- please... so sorry... so sorry... oh god... forgive me... aaahh!!"

Another harem slave silently turned a knob, pulling the victim's body ever so slightly further apart. Her fingers and toes spasmed helplessly. She could do nothing to save herself. She was completely defenseless.

When Dagon entered the room, he could not help but to stare at this scene with great lust. What he would give to own and possess so many beautiful slaves and force himself upon them as he desired! He greatly envied Bahamut, wishing it had been him who obtained the Sphinx's power instead of her.

He was a vile and disgusting creature no different from the Sphinx herself. Birds of a feather flocked together, as the old saying went.

"Oh! Hee, if it isn't Dagon!" Bahamut said, noticing him for the first time as he entered the room. "Took you long enough! Were you peeping on my girls again, you little lecher?"

Bahamut's shrill voice was irritating, but Dagon ignored it. He walked beside the tortured slave and paused to stare lustfully at her nude body, then turned his attention to Bahamut.

"Ahaha, lady Bahamut, my apologies. I am but a simple-minded male, after all. I cannot help but become enamored with all the pleasures of your kingdom. Naturally, I know better than to touch that which belongs to you."

"As you should!" Bahamut chirped.

She sat up, then placed her goblet of wine on a table beside her couch.

"What news do you bring?" Bahamut asked after a moment.

Dagon dropped to one knee and forced an expression of respect upon his face.

"Emperor Auger wishes for you to know that Satan has begun an assault on Heaven." Dagon summarized. "Mount Sinai is now under attack. When the time comes, we intend to bring you angels you can bind with your magic. We respectfully ask that you interrogate them and uncover Raphael's plans for the future."

Bahamut scoffed. "Hee! Satan is attacking Heaven directly? Did that fool not learn his lesson from last time? The angels have an unimaginable home field advantage! What an idiot!"

Dagon blinked. He was not used to hearing one of his Emperors so directly criticized.

"Our goal is not to defeat the angels." Dagon quickly explained. "Satan wishes to... acquire... something they possess. Thus, a few million casualties are a small price to pay."

Bahamut simmered down. "I see. That is more reasonable. Chee! Very well, if you bring me some new thralls, I shall interrogate them."

She paused, then sneered with her eyes.

"But you had better give me attractive ones! Most angels are so hideous I cannot stand to look at them! Pretentious beings, thinking their feathers are more beautiful than mine!"

Dagon nodded dumbly. He personally thought angels were quite fair and beautiful, but it seemed Bahamut held a different opinion. And was that *jealousy* in her voice? He couldn't be certain.

"Is there anything else?" Bahamut asked, after a time.

Dagon paused. He glanced at the helpless female slave lashed to the torture rack. She was so weak and delirious from pain that she hadn't even noticed he had entered the room.

"It would be such a shame for you to throw away this morsel..." Dagon said slowly. "Lady Bahamut, if you wish for her to suffer, why not give her to me? I assure you, I will take great pleasure in tormenting this errant slave until she begs for death."

Bahamut snorted. "Krrt, she already begs me for death. How pathetic of you, lustfully coveting my toys. Who do you think you are?"

She directed a glare full of rage at Dagon. He did not cower, but he did feel a flash of fear. Bahamut herself was not considered anything much, but the prestige she wielded among demonkind due to her unique abilities meant she was favored by the higher ups. If he blundered diplomatically here, they might execute him to get back on her good side!

Naturally, Dagon quickly lowered his head.

"Apologies, lady Bahamut. I spoke thoughtlessly. Please forgive this stupid and sinful male for his words."

Bahamut did not say anything for a short time.

Then, she clicked her tongue.

"Chrrrup! Perhaps your suggestion has some merit. I tire of doing everything myself around here. And maybe it would be fun watching you ravish this stupid and useless creature! I have changed my mind. Release her and take her right here on the spot."

Dagon's heart soared. He looked up in astonishment at Bahamut. "Lady Bahamut, do you truly mean it?"

"Hee! Of course I do!" Bahamut giggled evilly. "But! You had better put on a show for me! I wish to hear this woman scream and beg for mercy even more than she did earlier! You will do this for MY pleasure, not yours! If you fail, I will have you executed and none of your superiors will say a word! Are you sure you are willing to assume such a risk?!"

Dagon's soaring heart immediately plummeted from the heavens to hell. A cold icy feeling washed over his body. He lowered his eyes and fell into thought.

"If... I may be... so presumptuous..." Dagon said slowly. "I would be willing to do so... but only if the reward were commensurate to the risk."

"HEE! Listen to you, thinking you are big in the britches!" Bahamut chirped, squawking with laughter at him. "Are you trying to cut a *deal* with me, Dagon?"

"A deal, no." Dagon said, shaking his head respectfully. "A suggestion, that is all. How about this, lady Bahamut? If I succeed in torturing this slave to a level that satisfies you, you will consider calling upon me in the future for such matters? Not all of them, of course. But other times, if only to satisfy your hunger for variety! What powerful woman such as yourself does not crave a little novelty in her life?"

Bahamut listened silently to his suggestion. She rested an elbow on the couch's arm and tapped the tip of her beak as she looked up at the ceiling thoughtfully.

"Hee... this is indeed quite novel. No Baron has ever been so daring as to make such a request of me. But I must admit! I have grown a little tired of the same-old, same-old. I suppose it is worth a try! Why not give you one chance, hee?"

She waved her other hand flippantly.

"I accept your proposal. Unbind the wench and ravish her until I am satisfied! If you succeed, I will call upon you occasionally in the future!"

A disgusting smile spread across Dagon's face. Green corpse-like breath emitted from his mouth as he chuckled softly. "Worry not. I will go to any length to satisfy both of our cravings..."

Dagon stood up. He walked over to the table and unbound the woman's wrists, feeling his pants heat up as he gazed upon the succulent meal before him. The woman sagged helplessly, whimpering and unable to move her arms after hours of torture.

Dagon rubbed his palms together with glee. No other demon had ever been granted such a lucky encounter, and even if it resulted in his death, he intended to enjoy every last moment of his life.

"Come here, you tasty little treat..." Dagon whispered, as he reached down to unbind her ankles.

At that moment, the entire Citadel rumbled slightly.

It wasn't a forceful shaking, but one that felt like a minor earthquake. The rumbling passed after just a second or two.

"Hmm?" Bahamut grunted, lifting her eyes to look skyward. "What's this? There's something-"

RUMBLE.

The Citadel shook much more forcefully as a tremor five times stronger shook the halls!

This time, Bahamut stood up and looked into the sky.

"Someone is attacking the city's barrier! Who dares?! Dagon, what did you do?!"

"Me??" Dagon asked, just as shocked as her. "I didn't do anything!"

"You brought an invasion force here? You've betrayed me?!" Bahamut roared.

"No, no, this is a misunderstanding!" Dagon exclaimed, taking a step back. "You've got it wrong! I would never-"

At that moment, something happened Dagon never could have mentally conceived.

Enraged beyond belief, Bahamut clapped her palms together. Her body shook, and then she began to transform.

Never had anyone seen the Sphinx unleash her ancient power. For the first time, Dagon gazed with horror upon the bird-woman as she dropped to all fours and her body took on the figure of a three headed beast.

The head in the middle was Bahamut's head; that of a falcon.

The head on the left was one belonging to a lion.

The head on the right was one that resembled a massive cave bear.

Her body assumed the form of a lion, with four feathered wings similar to those of the angels.

Bahamut's lion head roared loud enough to shatter the eardrums of her closest slaves. Dagon hurriedly jumped away in fear as she leaped toward him and slashed her claws at him.

THUMP!!

Bahamut tore through his haphazard attempt to block and sent him flying! Dagon crashed into the far wall at the same time as another powerful rumbling shook the city of Sarabiya.

"It wasn't me!!" Dagon screamed, right before the head of a bear chomped at his neck, clamped onto his throat, and ripped it out with one swift tearing motion.

Dagon's words died in his mouth. Blood erupted from the terrible gash in his neck, and he fell to the ground, the life leaving his body.

"TRAITORRRS!!" Bahamut roared, before racing through the halls to arrive outside.

Ten more attacks fell upon the barrier protecting her city. When Bahamut emerged, she looked upward just in time to see a tiny figure descending through a hole in Sarabiya's mirage. The hole closed up behind the figure, and it levitated downward like the descent of an omniscient god.

Bahamut's keen eyes picked out the figure's appearance. It was an armored bipedal creature of some sort. Faceless, hidden behind a type of metallic alloy she could not identify.

"A HUMAN?" Bahamut roared. "WHAT HUMAN POSSESSES A POWER LIKE YOURS?! HOW DARE YOU ATTACK MY LAND!"

A male's voice spoke down to her from on high.

"You have something I want. And more than that, you do not deserve to exist any longer."

The Archseer had arrived.

Part 709: Sphinx Slaughter

January 29th, 2021. Sarabiya, Egypt.

Jason levitated above the Sphinx, his cold expression hidden behind the armor that enveloped him from head to toe.

The shell protecting him was not a T-REX, but instead a custom seamless platemail-design Jason had made for himself. Since he could wear any clothing instantly, he didn't need something nanite-based to slip into easily, and thus he could mitigate the molecular weakness of nanite-based armor.

Thus, his suit was made of malleable Wordsmithium engineered not entirely for hardness, but for fluidity. It was extremely comfortable to wear, and made of a self-healing alloy that would heal any damage done to it during the battle. It was especially effective at protecting its wearer from blunt attacks, though sharp attacks were not going to get through much easier.

Jason held a bo staff in his right hand, but not an ordinary one. It was made of pure Wordsmithium, and it had a glowing jewel set in the top and bottom of the staff, keeping it equally balanced. These two jewels shimmered with dazzling multi-colored light, their purpose unknown.

"I could kill you right now." Jason declared. "You are nothing before me but vermin. Yet, when I arrived and saw the state of your so-called 'empire', I felt disgust beyond reason. You deserve a fate worse than death."

"**YOU DARE SPEAK TO THIS QUEEN SO RUDELY?!**" Bahamut roared. "**YOU WILL DIE FOR YOUR INSOLENCE!!**"

She flapped her wings and leaped into the sky, rearing her paw back to strike.

Jason stared emptily at his would-be assailant. "How can you kill me when I'm already dead inside?"

Just before Bahamut's claw struck Jason's body, the lower gem on his staff changed colors, turning red. It snapped upward and struck the underside of her bear head, exploding the instant it made contact with infernal flames!

BOOM!!

Bahamut's momentum instantly reversed. Her body was send flying up into the sky from the impact, and she spun backwards three times, unable to stop her momentum. She finally flapped her wings and managed to slow her spinning down, only to see a figure flying toward her, directly in her path.

He teleported?! Bahamut thought.

A blue beam of light fell upon her spinning body and exploded, striking her lion head. Ice erupted in all directions, jarring her senses and causing her to plummet toward the ground. She crashed into the lower edge of her Citadel, breaking fifteen teeth in her lion's mouth and shattering just as many bones. For a brief moment, Bahamut ragdolled down the steps until she struck the ground. She lay there, unmoving, her body throbbing with pain she couldn't even properly feel.

The Sphinx's consciousness wavered. She felt a deep panic start to take hold of her body. Only two blows and she had already been reduced to such a state... who was this attacker? How was he so powerful?!

Bahamut had never publicly revealed the power of her Sphinx form. A long time ago, at some point after Egypt became a world Empire, long after the War in Heaven, she had grown sick and tired of one specific Demon Emperor. She had sneakily pursued him until he was somewhere all alone, transformed, and killed him in a fast but brutal fight.

The power of the Sphinx's transformation was terrifying! Her normal body was weak and pathetic, but so long as she properly transformed, she could kill certain Demon Emperors. Yet now, this new enemy was stronger then most Demon Emperors! How could he be so fearsome?!

A dull ringing in all of Bahamut's heads brought her back to reality. She woozily opened her eyes, then let out a scream when she saw a pair of boots right in front of her lion head's nose!

"Get up." Jason said, staring down on her like a wrathful god of vengeance. "Your death will not come immediately, because you do not deserve a quick end. I have seen what kind of creature you are, and I will not allow you to exist in this world for much longer. But until I make you disappear, I will ensure every last instant of your life is spent wallowing in terror."

Bahamut scrambled backward. She looked up at the faceless attacker in shock, her spirit already broken. She was a cowardly person at heart, and always relied on lies and

deception to defeat her foes. Her riddle magic served as a convenient way to permanently enslave anyone, but only if they played along. If they were strong enough to ignore her games, then her riddle magic served no purpose whatsoever!

Now that she had met a superior foe, someone who she could not hope to defeat, she quickly tried to think of contingency plans! The first one that came to mind was calling upon her demonic allies, but the problem was that her command crystal was inside her palace. If she could not activate it, then nobody would come to save her. The last person who visited her before Dagon had visited two years prior! That meant reinforcements were not going to waltz in through the front door by pure happenstance!

The next contingency would involve some sort of sneak attack that left her enemy crippled. But that was even more of a joke! She could feel that both of her front legs were badly injured to the point she could barely move them. Her claws were her strongest weapons with the greatest striking power.

How could she defeat this unknown enemy? How? How??!!

"You can't." Jason said, making a chill descend upon Bahamut's heart. "I have already considered all the angles. Your Sphinx Form is well known to me. In fact, I had two friends in the past who both assumed the form of the Sphinx. They told me all about its strengths and weaknesses."

Bahamut coughed ferociously, spitting teeth from her mouth. "Kuhak!! No- NO! That isn't possible! Jarnof was the only Sphinx before me! How could you know him?! You aren't a demon! You're clearly a human!"

"A human, yes. Jarnof, no." Jason said, taking a slow step toward Bahamut. "Riddle magic is interesting. If someone fails to guess the riddle, you enslave them. But if they guess correctly, they become the Sphinx. At the same time, if someone simply kills the Sphinx, they will also succeed in obtaining the Sphinx's powers."

Jason knelt down and hovered his faceless mask mere inches from Bahamut. He stared at her through the metal, making her shiver in fear.

"I could kill you in an instant. Take your power for myself. But I don't want your power, you filthy witch."

Bahamut's heart flew from hell to heaven. She looked at him with a mixture of surprise, hope, horror and dread.

"Y-you don't?" Bahamut shakily whispered.

"There is a slave among your ranks. Her name is Phoebe Berthold. Do you know her?" Jason asked.

Bahamut blinked. She looked at the ground, her mind racing.

One slave out of thousands. She had an incredible memory, but it was hardly eidetic, and when she factored in the thousands of slaves she had taken over the millennia, they all became a blur...

Jason waved his hand. An image of Phoebe materialized in midair.

"She was one of King Arthur's Knights of the Round Table. I have long admired this woman, and I wish to see her. I know she is still alive among your slaves, but I am not certain which one is her."

Jason cocked his head slightly.

"Have her come here. Release her from your Riddle Magic, and swear an oath of servitude to me. If you do, I will allow you to live."

Bahamut's icy blood immediately heated up.

That was all he wanted?! It was simple, far too easy a task to complete. But...

"If... if you simply killed me... you would become the Sphinx." Bahamut said, trembling at her own stupidity for uttering such words. "Y-you could release all my slaves with ease. Why, then, would you not...?"

"Because your power is not something I desire." Jason said, his voice gravelly. "I suppose if you'd prefer, I can simply kill you now."

His staff twitched as he started to move it, and Bahamut's pupils shrunk to pinpricks.

"N-no!! No, I am sorry, master! I will call her at once! Forgive m-m-my impudence!!"

Bahamut bowed her heads until they all struck the ground. She reached out with her powers and quickly searched the area. She vaguely remembered Phoebe's identity, as she had been one of the more noteworthy women Bahamut had enslaved in the past. Luckily, she found her.

"Th-the guards... at the front gate." Bahamut whispered. "One of them is the woman you seek. I have called her over. She will arrive soon!"

Jason remained on one knee. His faceless helmet seemed to stare at Bahamut with enough intensity to bore directly into her bones. She shivered in fright, unable to speak.

Thirty seconds later, the sound of heavy footsteps came running over. Jason turned to look, only to see an absolutely massive, armored figure approaching from behind.

This figure was none other than the gate guard who had conversed with Dagon earlier that day. The massive, intimidating monster slowed to a stop, then bowed its head toward Bahamut, seemingly uncaring of the one that threatened her life.

"Release her now." Jason said.

Bahamut bobbed her head up and down, praying this wasn't all just a dream. She lifted a paw, slowly and painfully, and made a motion with her claws, sending energy and power into the gate guard.

Within seconds, the monster began to shrink in stature. Down, down, down it fell, until it was a head shorter than Jason. Its black chitinous armor faded away, and slowly, the form of a white haired woman took form.

Phoebe.

Her eyes fluttered as she stood in place. She looked around in confusion, uncertain of what was happening.

"Phoebe Berthold." Jason said. "How are you feeling?"

His words were diplomatic and neutral, but in that moment, Bahamut sensed something about him change.

The words may have been neutral, but his tone had warmed slightly.

He had feelings for this woman!

Was it possible he loved her? Was that why he came all this way to rescue her? Maybe he didn't want to take a life in exchange for saving one.

Bahamut's eyes flickered with insight.

This man was soft! He wasn't a killer at all! That was why he was going to spare her life instead of doing the logical thing and killing the Sphinx!

Phoebe massaged her forehead, then looked around, assessing the situation.

"Where... am I?" Phoebe asked.

"You were a slave to the Sphinx." Jason said quietly. "But I have fought your enemy and forced her to free you. Do you remember now?"

Phoebe blinked. She looked down at the bloodied and crippled three-headed monster laying on the ground before the kneeling man.

She didn't recognize the monster, except for one of its heads. That bird-head! How could she ever forget!

"You!" Phoebe gasped. "It was *you* who tricked me! I remember now! When I was out in the wilderness, fleeing from Arthur's men..."

Bahamut shivered. If the man truly did have feelings for Phoebe, then any damning words she spoke might bring an executioner's axe upon Bahamut's neck. That was something she did not wish to happen.

Bahamut coughed again, spiting blood from her throat. "G-great one, you have beaten me and I have freed your woman. As such, I wish to treat you as my-"

Bahamut tried to continue speaking, but all of a sudden, her voice cut off. Her mouth sealed shut.

Her eyes widened. Bahamut tried to speak, to swear fealty to the man, but she couldn't! No matter how much she struggled, it was as if invisible chains had wrapped around the mouths of all three heads!

"So?" Jason asked menacingly, turning his attention to Bahamut's trembling figure. "Are you going to swear fealty to me, or have you had second thoughts?"

Bahamut's eyes widened. She tried desperately, with all her strength, but she couldn't even let out a squeak!

What power had sealed her mouth, and why now??

Jason lowered his head. He sighed loudly.

"So. This is how you are. A coward who will not even swear a simple oath. Lady Berthold, step forward please."

Phoebe nodded dumbly. She walked over to the man's side, uncertain of what he wanted.

"This creature, this trickster, is the Sphinx." Jason said. "She has used her magic to enslave countless souls, good and evil, for her own wicked purposes. I told her that so

long as she freed you and swore an oath to me as her king, I would forgive her trespasses. But as you can see, she does not even have the guts to do such a thing. She would rather die than use her power for good ends."

Bahamut's eyes widened. Phoebe's eyes narrowed.

No! No, that isn't true at all! Bahamut screamed in her head. *I will serve! I will! Spare me!!*

But if Jason heard her thoughts, he did not acknowledge them this time.

"What a wicked hellfiend indeed." Phoebe said, her eyes turning cold. "Memories are coming to me now. Echoes of some of the wicked deeds this creature forced me to do! She is an abomination!"

"Indeed she is." Jason said with a long sigh.

He stood up, rising a head above Phoebe, then turned to look at her.

"Please kill this creature." Jason said, holding out his staff. "If you do, you will obtain all of her powers, and you will be able to free all the people she has enslaved over the years. You will become the next Sphinx and gain the power to protect yourself."

Phoebe looked up at the faceless mask, feeling taken aback. "Me? But my lord, why would you not take her power for yourself? And why choose me of all people? I am no-one."

A moment passed. Jason reached up and touched the side of his head. His helmet vanished, revealing his face for the first time. Phoebe saw a blonde-haired young man with blue eyes. A face that was somewhat familiar, as he resembled someone she had once known...

"Because I am a Hero, like Arthur before me." Jason said. "Arthur died long ago, but I have spoken to his spirit and determined that you would be someone worthy of the Sphinx's title."

"Arthur... did?" Phoebe said, a spark lighting in her gaze. "But he... he should..."

"Hate you?" Jason asked. "No. Arthur would never. When next a chance arises, I will grant you an audience with him. You will see that his anger toward you was entirely a figment of your imagination."

Phoebe lowered her head. Her eyes glistened with tears.

"Arthur... never hated me..." Phoebe said quietly. "I... I... thank you, my lord. I shall not forget this debt I owe you."

Jason's expression flickered.

"No. You don't... owe me anything." Jason said quietly. "It is I who owes you."

Phoebe looked up at him, but Jason did not elaborate. He simply held out his staff.

"Take this weapon. Use it to strike down the monster Bahamut. Take her power for yourself. Only once she is dead and the power is in the hands of someone capable will I feel at ease."

Phoebe slowly nodded, but she hesitated.

This was not the same Phoebe who had spent years in the future alongside Jason. This was the Phoebe of the past, someone who was deeply compassionate and who had never taken a life. She was so compassionate that she had risked her own life to free the demons trapped in Arthur's prison, even if it meant she might face the executioner's block.

"I... I don't know if I can." Phoebe said quietly.

"You can, and you must." Jason said, holding the staff out a little further. "You cannot fathom the wicked deeds this monster has committed. Even as we speak, there is a helpless woman bound inside the palace, one Bahamut was torturing when I arrived. She is but one victim among countless others. If Bahamut does not deserve death, then nobody does."

That shook Phoebe to her core. She looked up at Jason's face, and what she saw was a man who had lost everything, yet pulled himself back from the brink of despair. His eyes were hardened, yet when he looked at her, she saw eyes glowing with hints of love. He had not yet lost his soul.

"...I understand." Phoebe said quietly. "Consider it done."

She took the staff from Jason's hands and turned to Bahamut. The Sphinx's eyes trembled violently. She wanted to scramble away, but she found that her body had been rooted in place by some unknown force! She was completely at Phoebe's mercy.

"Wicked beast." Phoebe said, taking a step toward Bahamut. "Have you any last words?"

From her perspective, Bahamut merely looked at her, frozen in fear. But in actuality, if Bahamut could speak, she would have said anything to save her own skin!

No, no, no, this isn't fair! I said I would swear fealty! I said I would! Hero, you BASTAAARD!

Behind Phoebe, Jason turned his head to look at Bahamut. An evil smile spread across his face.

[You get what you deserve.] Jason said, projecting his words directly into Bahamut's mind.

NOOOOO!!

Bahamut mentally shrieked one final time before Phoebe slammed the red gem against her middle head, blasting it to bits, spraying blood and gore in all directions. Strangely, the explosion didn't impact Phoebe at all, and not a speck of blood landed on her clothes or body. It was as if something invisible had protected her.

Phoebe shook as she saw the life leave the Sphinx's body. She had never killed in all her life, and now she had committed a brutal act of violence beyond anything she could imagine.

Even so, she was a resilient woman. She merely closed her eyes and gritted her teeth, turning to kneel toward Jason.

"My... my liege... I have done as you commanded, and, AHH-!"

The power of the Sphinx flooded into Phoebe's mind. She trembled, then fell forward, unconscious.

Before she could hit the ground, Jason had already knelt down and caught her. With Phoebe unconscious, he cradled her against his body and buried his face in her hair.

"Phoebe..." Jason whispered, closing his eyes. "Now, you will have enough power to protect yourself if I ever fail you again."

"But I won't let that happen." Jason said quietly. "I'll *never* let anyone hurt you."

Jason conjured a cot on the ground and allowed Phoebe to rest. Then he eradicated Bahamut's body from existence and went into her Citadel, freeing any bound slaves and forcing them to come outside with him. Before long, he had assembled thousands of men and women in the center square before Phoebe, who continued to lay in place, unmoving.

Jason did not know why Phoebe had fallen unconscious, but a quick check with his Wordsmithing revealed that she was not in any danger. It appeared her brain was altering its chemistry, and he determined she would wake up sooner rather than later. As for why Kar and Blinker had never had this happen, that was because they were innately stronger lifeforms than Phoebe, who was merely an ordinary human like Bahamut's previous self. Thus, the shock to Phoebe's system was greater.

Minutes passed. Eventually, Phoebe awoke as predicted. She opened her eyes, then sat up, carefully swinging her legs off the cot before looking at it in confusion. How had a cot appeared?

But she didn't have time to think of these things. She looked to her right and saw Jason standing there, then she looked ahead of herself and saw an army of men, women, and monsters surrounding her. They were all standing loosely, their expressions blank, as if they had no souls.

"Do you have the Sphinx's powers now?" Jason asked.

Phoebe thought for a moment, then she nodded.

"I do." Phoebe said quietly.

"Use them now. Free these people from their bondage." Jason said. "In the future, I will train you to use your powers properly."

"Alright." Phoebe said.

She slowly stood up, facing the swarm of creatures. Instinctively, she knew how the Sphinx's powers worked. That knowledge had been imprinted upon her mind.

Phoebe lifted her arms into the air.

"You are free!" She commanded.

The monstrous figures shook. The men and women trembled.

All at once, it was as if a mass-illusion spell had been ripped down. Humans, monsters, demons, and angels alike began appearing among the crowd. Jason was shocked to see the angels, as Bahamut had never had any of them among her slaves in the future. Perhaps, over 100,000 years, she had killed them all. Perhaps she had been commanded to do so by the demons, or perhaps she killed them merely for the thrill of rendering their species extinct.

Either way, the mass illusion broke. Cries of surprise went up among the crowd. People looked around, disturbed by their change in surroundings, and Jason smiled grimly.

"One more task taken off my list." Jason said to himself.

He had put one of his greatest fears to rest. From this day forward, Bahamut would no longer threaten the people of Earth.

Even better, Phoebe was in no danger of dying due to Bahamut's whims.

The situation was improving, if only a little at a time...

Part 710: Rekindled Flame

January 29th, 2021. Sarabiya, Egypt.

Men and women looked around in confusion. They remembered little of their past few hundreds, or even thousands of years of life. For some of them, the memories were more tangible than for the others. They could remember some of the acts they had committed. A scant few remembered everything. But by and large, most of Bahamut's victims had essentially stepped through a doorway into the future. They didn't know where they were or how much the world had changed.

They didn't even know how much time had passed.

Jason stepped forward. His movements, and his distinctive futuristic armor immediately drew the gazes of everyone present.

"Greetings, all of you! I am Jason Hiro, the legendary Archseer! I am a Hero of humanity, and your liberator! You should all feel proud to be in my presence, hahahaha!!"

Jason puffed out his chest and assumed a braggadocios person, laughing haughtily as if he were a god looking down upon all of creation. He lifted his arms in a manner most grand, and spread out his fingers as if trying to seize the light of day.

"The evil villain, Bahamut, the Sphinx of Egypt, took each and every one of you captive with her riddle magic! She turned you into her thralls and put you in a state of mental fugue. Some of you have been her slaves for thousands of years, some for hundreds, and a small number for mere decades. But I assure you, the world you live in now is one far different from when she enslaved you. Your families are long dead, the state of the planet has changed, and even the technology level of civilization has greatly advanced."

He continued. "Behind me is the new Sphinx. Her name is Phoebe Berthold, the one who broke free of her chains to slay your shared tormentor! A pupil of the legendary Hero, King Arthur, she stole the Sphinx's power and has sworn never to use it to cause harm again. You may serve her, or you may go on your way as you please. I will not forbid any of you from taking whichever action you desire."

"However!" Jason exclaimed. "The world you know is long gone. If you step out into the current one without any knowledge of its situation, you are likely to meet your

demise. I advise you to stay here, at least for a while. I will host educational classes to bring you all up to speed on the state of the world and allow you to make your decisions then!"

Jason paused for the briefest of moments. He quickly scanned the people around him. Though their numbers were vast, numbering in the thousands, the emotions they were feeling were easy to determine based on their facial expressions.

The humans looked deeply disturbed. As mortals with short lifespans, the knowledge that their friends and family were long dead had clearly left a mark on their psyche. They seemed defeated and lost. He decided right then and there that between ninety and one hundred percent of the humans would choose to stay on his side.

But the monsters, angels, and demons were a different story. Some species of monsters were not immortal, but most were. The same was true of angels and demons. They almost certainly still had friends and family still among the living. Jason determined that less than ten percent would be inclined to stay with him for any duration of time.

That was alright. He didn't value these scraps Bahamut had enslaved all that highly. There were five angels present, and four of them were Lazarites. Only one was a pureblood. Among the demons, there seemed to be about twenty, and none of them ranked above the level of a Demon Lord.

Just as Jason was about to write them off, he suddenly spotted a familiar face among the monsters.

Doctor Fathy!

She was the third most famous doctor in the future, after Belial and Leeroy, a Harpie woman whose natural medical skills towered above those of surgeons born in the 21st century. How she acquired such formidable medical skills was anyone's guess. The fact she competed with two Demon Emperors known for their healing skills said a lot.

Naturally, she did not know who Jason was. She merely stared at him silently, along with all the other people.

At the same time as Jason was speaking, the angels and demons present were side-eyeing each other. They may have just awoken from a forced slumber, but their hatred for one another ran bone deep. There was no way they would become chummy with each other just like that.

Phoebe looked at Jason's back. She was surprised that he had given her the credit for slaying Bahamut. While this was technically true, she certainly did not break free of Bahamut's control. Her new position was entirely granted by his mercy.

As such, her heart warmed toward him noticeably.

"I have studied the ancient records of Bahamut." Jason declared, waving his arm in a grandiose manner. "I know many of your names, but some of you were not in her scrolls. I would very much like to meet you all after this, and speak to you one on one. You may refuse! Don't feel that you're under any obligation to follow me. If you want, you can walk out into the desert right now!"

Jason paused, then cocked his head.

"But, in the spirit of gratitude for saving your lives, I hope you would show myself and the new Sphinx a little leeway."

Many people subtly nodded. His request was fair. They were all a little out of sorts, and getting to speak to this 'Hero' certainly wouldn't hurt.

For the humans who knew what a Hero was, Jason's identity was extremely impressive! They immediately wanted to forge a connection with him for a variety of reasons.

For the humans who did not, the fact that he was a human and one of their saviors certainly bought him a lot of goodwill, even if his manner of speaking was a little too ostentatious for their tastes.

The angels definitely knew who he was, as did the demons. Even an idiot demon would know that a Hero was a big deal. These types secretly decided to meet with him for at least the purpose of collecting information on him. Whether they liked him and stayed, or left and gave that information to their leaders would be up for debate when the time came...

And finally, the monsters. Among them were Orcs, Goblins, Harpies, Felaris, Minotaurs, Kobolds, Fairies, and plenty of other scattered types that typically hid themselves from the human world. These types had opinions that fluctuated between those shared with the humans and those shared by the angels and demons. Their allegiances were only known to them.

But Jason was confident. He believed he could raise that 10% chance of recruitment to 25% or even 50% if he spoke to them the right way.

As for the ones who intended to sell information of him back to their masters?

How could he let *that* happen? Naturally, once they left the desert, their memories would be wiped, or their existences would be extinguished, either fate determined by what Jason felt was most appropriate depending on their identity. Only the Wordsmith would benefit from these discussions, not his enemies.

"Everyone! I look forward to speaking to all of you!" Jason declared. "For now, simply walk around and familiarize yourselves with this oasis. There are homes here, temporary shelters suitable for you to live in. I will be having an assistant of mine completely overhaul this land in the near future!"

The crowd loudly clapped and cheered, though some of the people present had more muted reactions than the rest. Those few did not know this, but Jason had instantly recorded and cataloged everyone's reactions. He had already begun compiling information to determine who was most trustworthy, and he would not stop until his Work was done.

That was not going to happen for a very, very long time.

With a flourish, Jason spun on his heel, then took Phoebe's arm with his hand and guided her away. She still seemed somewhat dazed by the rapid change in her life situation.

"Walk with me." Jason said.

She nodded and strode beside him without complaint.

Leaving the crowd behind, Jason let them deal with matters themselves. He knew there was a chance fights might immediately start breaking out, but he had taken countermeasures already. Any troublemakers would meet a swift and decisive end. Plus, by letting everyone sort themselves out, he would be able to see if any of them had leadership experience.

Jason already knew Neil was among the people present, but he didn't immediately seek the man out. Jason had only one thing on his mind at this moment, and it was something he had been aching to do for a long time...

He led Phoebe back inside Bahamut's Citadel. Now, with all the slaves freed, it was completely silent inside. Their footsteps seemed to echo for miles into the distance as they walked the corridors leading down into the heart of the pyramid.

"My lord." Phoebe said, eventually breaking the silence. "Why did you choose for me to become the Sphinx? I still do not understand."

My lord.

My lord.

Her formal words crashed against Jason's head, making him feel somewhat sick to his stomach. Phoebe had no idea who he was, or how much she mattered to him. She spoke to him as if he were a stranger, because to her, *he was*.

Jason swallowed heavily. He thought for a moment before replying.

"Because I need someone I can trust, and you're the best candidate here." Jason said quietly.

"What makes you think I am trustworthy, my liege?" Phoebe pressed further. "For all you know, I could be a liar and a thief."

"Unlikely." Jason replied. "My discussions with Arthur granted me great insight. You are a woman of conviction. You abandoned your kingdom to save innocent demons, even knowing it would likely carry the penalty of death. I need someone with strong convictions by my side... assuming you want to be there in the first place."

Jason's heart skipped a beat. This was the first time he was giving Phoebe a chance to abandon him and leave, and he suddenly felt a twinge of fear she might just do that!

But she didn't.

"Please do not jest, my lord." Phoebe said, shaking her head politely. "You have saved my life and granted me a power which belonged to the former Sphinx. The burden is heavy, but I feel obliged to rise to the occasion. I will not abandon you so long as you need me."

Jason turned his head slightly to look at her as they walked. They passed by a lit torch sconce on the wall, and its flames illuminated her smiling face.

Her smile... warmed his heart. He could not help but smile back.

"That's good." Jason said. "That's... good."

He looked away. Phoebe raised an eyebrow as she noticed something about him felt off.

"Is something the matter, my liege? You seem displeased."

"I'm not." Jason said. "In fact, I'm happier now than I've felt in the better part of a year. But along with that joy is... a deep sense of sadness. It's hard to explain."

"You do not have to speak of it if you do not wish to do so." Phoebe said, before pausing and adding, "though, if you ever wish to unburden your heart, I am your faithful servant. I will always be here for you."

Jason slowed his pace, then stopped in the middle of the hallway. He stared into the distance, uncertain of what to say.

"...I. I lost. I lost my wife." Jason said, his words slow and halting. "She died. It was my fault. Or, at the very least, my inaction, my failure to anticipate my enemy's movements... is what caused her death."

Phoebe bowed her head slightly. She folded her hands in front of herself and listened quietly.

"I've been lost for so long." Jason said. "I'm trying to use my power to fight a war for the fate of humanity. If it wasn't for the fact that I found my daughter alive and well, I don't think I'd be here right now."

Phoebe glanced at him for a split-second, then looked away.

"I am glad you did not walk the wrong path, my lord." Phoebe said softly. "Else, I would still be trapped within Bahamut's grasp. So would many other people. I do not know what caused your wife's death, but I believe she would be unhappy if she were to find out you blamed yourself."

Jason turned his head. He looked at the top of Phoebe's beautiful white hair. He felt a pang of longing... he wanted to reach out and hug her, to kiss her, to pull her into his embrace and reunite with her...

But he couldn't do that. He didn't *deserve* such joy.

"You're probably right." Jason muttered. "My wife was a good person. She was the best person I've ever known. She wouldn't blame me for what happened. But it doesn't matter now. Because it did happen. And I blame myself. I can never forgive myself."

Jason cleared his throat, but some stubborn phlegm remained stuck in place, so his voice turned slightly raspy.

"I... I keep forcing myself to go on. To push forward. To continue trying to make a better world for my daughter, and for all the other people who depend on me. But truthfully, my will has weakened a lot lately. I look in the mirror and want to kill the man looking back at me. I hate him so much. I hate his weakness. I hate his indecision. More than that, I hate that I spent so little time with my wife before she died."

"What do you mean?" Phoebe asked. "You weren't living with her?"

Jason ground his teeth against each other. "No. I wasn't. She was pregnant with our son, and I was living inside a time-accelerated temporal dimension. I feared the time flow might hurt her or the baby, so I left her in Realspace, visiting occasionally. Even when she had the boy, I didn't bring her inside for fear she might end up injured from the timeflow distortions-"

Jason glanced at Phoebe, only to see that she appeared completely confused.

"F-forgive me, my lord." Phoebe said, feeling flustered under his gaze. "This... um... time flow... dimension... I do not understand these words. I apologize for my inadequacy."

She quickly bowed her head, feeling shameful before him, yet what she didn't know was that Jason felt even worse than she did.

This Phoebe had not come into contact with Solomon's Crown. She was merely an above-average medieval woman when it came to intellect. She had no concept of time travel, different dimensions, or other science fiction-like terminology.

The knowledge that his wife had been reduced to such a state made Jason's heart ache. He massaged his eyes and sighed.

"No, it's my fault. In time, I will grant you a new boon that will greatly enhance your cognitive capabilities. I believe you could become one of the smartest people on Earth, given the right resources."

Phoebe looked up at him in astonishment. Then, she burst into laughter.

"Hahaha, oh, my liege, you do have a sense of humor! I am quite slow when it comes to complex matters, but I am a good listener. It's one of my few traits I feel pride towards!"

"I'm not joking." Jason said. "Here, let's rest in Bahamut's throne room. I have a few things I'd like to inform you of."

Jason led her into the heart of the Citadel. He gestured toward Bahamut's throne, but she simply turned and looked at him, for the first time, as if he were a fool.

"...Forgive me, but I would prefer not to sit there." Phoebe said. "That throne is more appropriate for a Hero such as yourself."

"Let's just agree it's an ugly and tacky throne and it'll be one of the first things we eliminate." Jason joked, smiling genuinely in spite of his earlier pain.

He really enjoyed being able to talk to Phoebe again, even if she wasn't exactly... *his* Phoebe.

He sat on a couch that had previously been intended for Bahamut's harem girls, and Phoebe sat beside him, though she put half a person's distance between them. They were strangers, after all.

"Over the coming days," Jason said, "I am going to be deceiving a lot of people. You are the only person I'm about to tell the truth. Please keep what I am about to say completely confidential."

Phoebe's eyes widened. "O-of course, my liege. Consider it done. But again I must ask, why are you so sure you can trust me?"

Jason hesitated.

"...I am friends with many Heroes. I have learned of a coming war that will soon engulf the Earth. I have also learned of the identities of certain people who will be instrumental in winning the war for both sides. You are one of those people."

Phoebe balked. "Me? But I am just an ordinary woman-"

"Ordinary no more." Jason interrupted. "You now possess the power of the Sphinx. And unlike that wastrel Bahamut, who squandered her power to pursue riches and depravity, you will be able to put its power to better use. You are a warrior at heart, a woman who is extremely courageous, and formerly the only female member of the Knights of the Round Table."

He paused.

"Please do not sell yourself short. You are far from ordinary, Phoebe."

Phoebe smiled at him, then rubbed her hands together. She didn't know why, but she really liked the way he spoke to her.

"You seem like a nice young man." Phoebe said. "How long were you, um, married?"

Jason stared at her for a moment. He coughed.

"Um. We were married, err, in real terms, six years. In terms of my lived life... a bit over three hundred years."

"Th-th-three HUNDRED years?!" Phoebe exclaimed, looking at him aghast. "Wha- I, I mean, HOW??"

"Let's not worry about that right now." Jason said, as he chuckled and shook his head. "I'm going to tell you something important now, so pay attention."

He paused to gather his thoughts.

"In public, my title is the Archseer. I profess to be a prophet who sees the future, and has the power to assimilate knowledge quickly, making myself a powerful frontline combatant. But this is a deception. My true title is Wordsmith. I have the ability to create nearly anything by speaking a single Word of Power. For example, **Cup!**"

Jason held out his hand, and a small glass cup appeared in his palm. Phoebe flinched when it appeared. Her eyes became as wide as saucers.

"You can summon objects?" She asked.

"I can do a lot more than that." Jason answered. "I can conjure and shoot fireballs, unleash a hail of arrows upon my enemies, create suits of armor like the one I'm wearing... and I can even create entire realms and lands filled with machinery and magical architecture beyond your imagination. I am a fairly good fighter, but my combat skills pale in comparison to legends like Arthur. That is why I am focusing on building an army of trustworthy people and using my powers to enhance all of them, so they can solve my deficiencies. I helped you obtain the Sphinx's power, and I will upgrade your mind and other bodily abilities as well, so that you may defend yourself and humanity in the coming future war."

Phoebe nodded solemnly. She felt that the weight of her decision to accept the Sphinx's power was growing heavier by the hour, but it was a burden she was willing to bear.

"Thus," Jason continued, "I am going to have to ask you to help me play a little trick on the others outside. I already know that some of them will be trustworthy warriors for humanity, but I cannot say that is true of all of them. Are you willing to help me interview

them, in your new role as the Sphinx, and weed out the undesirables while keeping your eyes peeled for diamonds in the rough?"

Phoebe thought for a moment. She didn't immediately accept, but instead tapped her finger to her lips and thought carefully about everything she had learned.

Eventually, she nodded, a grave look of certainty on her face. "Of course. I will assist you, Wordsmith. I will not speak of any matters you tell me in confidence."

"Haha." Jason chuckled lightly. "I know. I'll be counting on you to be my number one confidante and assistant, Phoebe."

She stood up, then turned and dropped to one knee, bowing before him.

"I am at your service, my liege. You honor me with your words."

Seeing his wife bowing to him, Jason's eyes shook.

He reached out, then rested his palm on top of her head.

"No... no more of this, Phoebe. From now on, please just call me... Jason. I won't feel at ease if you're so formal around me."

Phoebe quickly lifted her head. "No, I... I don't think that's appropriate, my lord. It is not right for a commoner to speak to her King, a Hero no less, with such a familiar tone."

Jason pulled his hand away and smiled.

"Please. Phoebe, I'm begging you. Just call me by my name. Alright?"

Phoebe met his gaze. She looked into his eyes, and saw a strange warmness mixed with isolation that she couldn't properly identify. Something about him seemed like he knew her better than he knew himself, but also that he was carrying a burden greater than she could fathom.

Phoebe lowered her eyes.

She sighed softly.

"Very well... Lord Jason."

"Just Jason. No 'lord' or 'sir' or 'king' or 'liege', Got it?" Jason retorted.

"I understand. My apologies... Jason." Phoebe said.

Speaking his name so plainly felt wrong on many levels, but when she met his eyes again, she saw that his smile had deepened, ever so slightly, and that feeling of wrongness

didn't feel as sharp as before.

She quite liked the way it felt to call him by his name.

"I'm glad to have you by my side, Phoebe." Jason said.

Part 711: S.I.G.I.L.

January 29th, 2021. Sarabiya, Egypt.

Not even thirty minutes after taking Phoebe inside to talk to her privately, Jason exited the Citadel, once again assuming his macho persona full of bravado. Phoebe followed along behind him, giving him strange looks as his entire attitude drastically changed, and not in the sort of way mere play-acting could achieve.

"Hahahaha! Everyone, come out at once! I have something to tell all of you!" Jason shouted, his voice projecting across the entire city.

It took a few minutes, but men and women, humans, angels, demons and monsters all eventually made their way back to the bottom of the pyramid, stopping to stand and stare at Jason and Phoebe. By now, a few cliques had faintly started to form, with some people befriending others, whispering to their new friends conspiratorially as they wondered what the Archseer was going to say now.

He was certainly an odd fellow. His demeanor was over the top, but he mostly seemed like a dumb idiot who meant them no harm. He was nothing if not sincere.

"Thank you all for coming back!" Jason yelled. "You are truly fortunate! I have spoken with the Sphinx, and she has something to say to all of you!"

Jason took a step to the side and flippantly gestured toward Phoebe. She raised an eyebrow at him, then stepped forward to address the people.

"The Hero is currently in control of two Divine Lands." Phoebe explained. "The Divine Land of Earth, and the Divine Land of the Stars. Where you are now is the Divine Land of the Earth, currently named Sarabiya. However, that name was given to it by its former master. We will take this land, and the fruits of all our collective labor, and rebuild it into something new."

She paused.

"After all, it was us, Bahamut's slaves, who built this land. It is appropriate we reap the benefits of living here."

A man near the front raised his hand. Jason glanced at him. He was surprised to see that the one who wished to speak was none other than Makoto Ueda. In the far future, he

had been Neil's spiritual advisor before Buddha returned from the grave and took over his body.

"Miss Berthold. Lady Sphinx." Makoto said, bowing politely. "I am not opposed to staying here, but from what we have gathered, Sarabiya is an isolated land in the middle of a desert. There are no riches to speak of. Without constant supplies from the outside world, we will quickly run out of food. Have you considered this?"

"I have." Phoebe said, nodding at him. "That is why I am referring to this city as a Divine Land of Earth. There is more to it than meets the eye. After speaking to the Hero, I have come to learn that the world we live in now is one that has drastically changed from before Bahamut took me, and all of you, to be her slaves. For starters, in this era, there is no longer only one Trueborn Hero. There are two."

Plenty of people had no idea what Phoebe was talking about. But for those who did, they were shocked to their core.

The only pureblooded angel present suddenly pushed his way to the front. He was a tall and handsome fellow, seemingly in his 50's by human standards, with bushy eyebrows and brilliant white hair. He wore simple white robes and did not seem to be an angel of any particular importance, but purebloods were rare in these times.

"Two heroes?!" The angel exclaimed. "Lady Berthold, I must protest. Such a concept art impossible! The Heroic Aura doth not function in such a manner!"

"Not before, but it does now!" Jason said, flashing the angel a big thumbs up. "And what's your name anyway? You're one of the oddest ones out here."

The male angel did not balk at being called upon. He simply shook his head, lowered his eyes, and sighed. "Verily, I am Almar. A Seraph of no particular renown. Bahamut captured me by chance when Archangel Camael dispatched me on a mission to the human world five hundred years ago."

Jason quickly searched his memories. He had never heard of an angel named Almar at any point during the Ancient Era, so this fellow probably was a nobody. Even so, pureblooded angels were so rare these days that it couldn't hurt to treat him with respect and get to know him a little better. Who knew if such caution might pay dividends in the future?

"I see! Well, Almar, it turns out you're wrong! I'm not the only Trueborn Hero of this generation. There's another named Cat Mask, and the number of Lowborn Heroes will absolutely blow your mind. There are already a dozen, with more soon to be found!"

"A dozen?!" Almar exclaimed, his face turning pale. "Nay, nay! I say unto thee, this is surely a ruse!"

Jason smirked. "It's not. Why don't you let the Sphinx speak first? She'll explain everything."

Almar stared at Jason for a moment, uncertain about whether the Archseer was telling the truth or not. Even so, he eventually nodded, then stepped back into line. Many demons gave him a side-eye. It seemed they had at least heard his name before. Maybe he wasn't as much of a nobody as he claimed.

"As I was saying," Phoebe continued. "This era is different from the ones in which you lot originated. Not only are there more Heroes, but the technology level is vastly superior to that of even just a few decades before. I'm not entirely certain just how different it is, but the Archseer tells me the difference is like that between Heaven and Earth! We are not living in familiar times."

She paused. "As we speak, the demons are marching on Heaven. They have begun a full-scale assault, intending to kill the angels and take control over the Earth. It will take them time to achieve such a feat, but you can be assured the appearance of so many Heroes has sparked the fear of the Creator in them."

"Heaven is in danger?!" Almar gasped.

"Sounds like the Emperors are finally gonna rid the world of your filth, pigeon!" One of the Demon Lords nearby laughed. Jason didn't recognize him. He wore a light green tunic and head feathers in his hair. His face appeared to have had streaks of black painted under his eyes and around the rest of his face in geometric patterns, or perhaps those were tattoos. He looked fierce, but weak.

"Dost thou intendeth to leave this place and return to thy masters' side?!" Almar accused, turning on his heel to point a hostile finger at the Demon Lord. "Verily, I shall not allow thee!"

Jason quietly sighed. It seemed tensions would boil over soon, and he would need to intervene. But before he could make a move, Phoebe suddenly stormed aggressively

forward and stood between the two.

"You! Demon! State your name!" She shouted, startling the one who had mouthed off.

The demon glared at her. "What's my name matter to you, woman? You gonna enslave me again? Like we demons don't know what you're really up to! You're planning to kill us all anyway!"

"Who said I was going to kill you?" Phoebe scoffed. "I am Phoebe Berthold, former Knight of Camelot. Long ago, I freed many demons who King Arthur had trapped in his dungeon, knowing it would likely bring about a sentence of death upon me. Among humans, I can be considered to be more sympathetic to your plights."

Her expression hardened. "But that does not mean I will tolerate bullies, brutes, and thugs! If you cannot show respect to others, then perhaps killing you would indeed be a wise decision!"

The Demon Lord paled slightly. "H-hey, lady. No need to get all crazy or anything! Okay, look, uh, I'm... Vex. I'm the Lord of Lizards. B-but don't think that means I'm all sketchy and evil or anything! I'm totally a nice guy! I can get along with anyone, promise!"

Just like that, Vex's intimidation factor plunged into the negative. Faced with Phoebe's fierce glower, he practically wilted into a shivering ball of nerves.

"You had better hope so." Phoebe said, sweeping her gaze across all the assembled demons and angels. "I will not tolerate infighting! So long as you are in this land, you will be living under my rules. They are simple, but strict. We are allies, and allies do not cause harm to one another! If you cannot live by that standard, then I will not allow you to stay!"

Many people looked at her in surprise. Phoebe was small, but fiery. And nobody really knew what the powers of the Sphinx were, so they didn't want to be the first to start any problems. Who knew if she could beat the crap out of them with strange monstrous strength... or *worse*?

Of course, there was also the fact that she was backed by the Trueborn, and his abilities were a mystery as well. Considering Bahamut had reigned supreme for thousands of years, and he had helped topple her, he couldn't be a featherweight. There was more to the Archseer than they had yet seen.

With Phoebe's intervention, the fight between the angels and demons stopped, at least temporarily, before it had even begun. Jason smiled. That was the Phoebe he knew.

She turned around and strode back to her original spot, then crossed her arms and looked down her chin at everyone gathered.

"To transform this city into a true Divine Land, the Archseer will be enlisting one of the Heroes among his ranks to offer us her assistance. She possesses incredible powers that allow her to construct technology far beyond your wildest imaginations. With her help, we will rebuild Sarabiya into a world power! We will swallow the entirety of the Western Desert, turning this barren wasteland into a paradise unlike any other!"

The crowd listened with interest. Her words were beyond their expectations. What Hero did Jason have at his beck and call who could wield such formidable powers? Could she really do as Phoebe claimed?

Jason gestured to the right of himself and Phoebe. With a flash of light, a woman suddenly appeared.

She was a mature woman, roughly forty years of age. She wore a smart blue suit, vaguely military in design, and had short brown hair in a bob cut, as well as green eyes. She wore glasses, and seemed as if she had the air of a librarian or a scholar. Nobody recognized her.

"Everyone." The woman said. "I am Jessica Harper. You may call me Miss Harper. My heroic title is the Great Builder."

Jessica's voice was calm but stern. She had an inviolable aura, far different from the haughty Archseer. She seemed to be in full control of herself and her emotions. Everything about her was in its proper place.

Nobody said a word. They simply watched silently as Jessica turned around and waved her hand toward Bahamut's Citadel.

Suddenly, the ground rumbled. The eyes of every man and woman went wide as the Citadel began to violently shake. All at once, it collapsed into a massive pile of sand, wiping out all of the hard work that had been put into maintaining it over the millennia. Just like that, a historic landmark was erased from history, leaving all who saw it shocked out of their wits!

But Jessica was not done there. She waved her hand again, causing the sand to shift its shape once more. It rapidly flew into the air, transforming into a massive and majestic building which appeared to be made in the image of Ancient Greece and Ancient Egypt both. Towering statues of a male and female soldier emerged from the ground, each one a hundred feet tell. They wore strange futuristic armor nobody had ever seen before, faceless helmets that shrouded their faces, and seemed to be holding weapons that only someone like Jason would recognize as energy weapons from the future.

The building behind them turned into a ten-story college with tall Greek pillars holding up its roof awning. Jessica rapidly constructed the inside of the building, then gestured for everyone to follow her.

Jason, Phoebe, and Jessica led the way for the thousands of Bahamut's former slaves behind them. They arrived inside a massive marbled hall where a model of the Sol system levitated in the air. The planets slowly spun in place, accurately revealing their current position in the star system, hovering tens of feet in the air. A galactic terrarium was present inside, with murals all over the ceiling and walls showing thousands of specks of light. These were not mere decorations, but accurate depictions of the positions of stars in the Milky Way, as viewed from Earth.

Many people gasped in amazement. Almar's jaw dropped as he beheld something he never could have imagined in all his life.

"This power belongeth to a mere Lowborn? Unbelievable. Even Archangel Uzziel could not build such a world wonder in less than a minute! My eyes hath truly been opened!"

Deeper inside the structure, there were vast terrariums crawling with plants, animals, bugs, all forming a self-maintaining ecosystem. This was even more ludicrous than what they had seen in the entry hall, because how could sand be turned into genuine living beings?! If Jessica could conjure life from dust, then it truly seemed they would not want for resources anytime soon!

Many of the demons began to grow fearful. The Great Builder alone was capable of transforming humanity into a terrifying powerhouse. If they combined the fact that she was a lowborn with the fact the Archseer was a Trueborn... just how powerful was the Archseer? And what of the other Heroes he said were also working under him? Just how strong had humanity become since Bahamut enslaved them?!

"I told you guys Jessica was awesome!" Jason shouted, projecting his voice loudly. "And that's not all! She can also-"

"Silence." Jessica said, instantly shutting the Archseer down. "Fool. All you do is run your mouth. Do not speak until I have given you permission to do so. A buffoon should know when to keep his mouth shut."

Jason stammered slightly, but when Jessica glared at him, he coughed and looked away, unwilling to meet her gaze.

Just like that, Jessica established visual dominance over him, making herself seem exceeding powerful and irreplaceable. Without any excessive words, she had raised her status in the eyes of everyone present. Never had they heard of a mere Lowborn successfully standing up to a Trueborn, but it seemed her value was high enough in the Archseer's eyes that he didn't dare speak back or give her any lip.

Jessica turned to the audience, her face unsmiling.

"Hmph. If you rabble think this to be the limit of what I can accomplish, then I ask one of you to step forward. I will transform him or her into a powerhouse on the spot."

Several people's eyes widened. Before anyone could react, one of the demons quickly jumped forward. "Me! Me please! I volunteer!"

Jessica raised an eyebrow. It was Vex, the loudmouth from earlier. Since he was a demon, it didn't entirely seem appropriate for him to receive the first honors, but...

"Very well." Jessica said, as if his species didn't matter to her in the slightest. "Behold."

She waved her hand, and from behind Vex, the audience looked at him, waiting for something to happen. However, nothing seemed to change.

Vex looked at his arms, his legs, then back at Jessica, eager and expectant.

"...Eh?" Vex grunted. "Did I... miss something?"

"Look at your chest." Jessica said.

And so he did. Vex glanced down, only now noticing there was a small silver disc affixed to the front of his tunic. It was small, barely three inches in diameter, and barely the thickness of three coins stacked on top of each other. It didn't seem special at all, and otherwise appeared to be an ordinary piece of metal.

"Turn around and show everyone." Jessica instructed. "Then touch the Activation Dial and allow yourself to Ascend."

Vex stared at her, then he nodded dumbly. "Oh. Okaaay..."

Slowly, he turned around. He gave everyone a good look at the metal circle pinned to his chest, and they all scratched their heads in confusion. It really didn't look like much.

After a moment's hesitation, Vex reached up with his hand and held it just shy of touching the circle.

"Err, what's gonna happen?" Vex asked, glancing back at Jessica.

"You will see." She said cryptically, her arms crossed, a solemn expression on her face.

Vex swallowed his saliva. He was not a brave person, but he didn't think Jessica was going to hurt him. After gritting his teeth, he tapped the dial.

A surge of blue light radiated out of the dial and swept across his body. It was as if a projector had been aimed at Vex and expanded a cone of light across his chest, radiating out in all directions from the origin point. A moment later, Vex's skin because to change color. His eyes widened in horror as it changed from red to black, and then his blood changed color as well, turning bright, neon green. His veins lit up across his body, standing out dramatically from his skin tone.

The change was rapid and immediate. Vex's very biology shifted on the molecular level. His skin hardened to a level that even Demonstone would envy. His eyes became pure green and glowed with light, causing his vision to improve even beyond that of a demon's standard physiology. He gasped as he realized he could look at his body and see every individual strand of hair, as well as microscopic bacteria crawling on his skin.

Vex's fingers turned into claws. His teeth sharpened. He felt alive. Powerful!

He felt powerful!

His muscles strengthened. Even his toes felt as if they could crush granite into powder. In an instant, his fear vanished as his mind sharpened!

"Hahahaha!!" Vex cackled. "This is amazing! This is awesome! What the heck did you do to me?!"

"I have made you the first ever user of SIGIL." Jessica said, turning up her nose at the marvelous piece of technology. She did not seem all that impressed by it, as if it were

merely the stepping stone to a far superior technology in the future. "The Synthetic Integrated Growth Infusion Layer, or SIGIL for short, is a device that alters the user's body chemistry on a subatomic level. It is the next evolution of a more primitive design known as a T-REX... not that any of you need bother yourselves with that old piece of trash."

She continued. "The SIGIL has greater effectiveness on weaker beings than on stronger ones. Past a certain level of strength, it has no effect on a user at all. Additionally, every user's biology will be affected differently. Some people will obtain greater benefits than others due to their individual constitutions. It seems yours gave you black skin and green blood, but this will not be the case for everyone else."

The other demons looked enviously at Vex. The angels looked at him in disgust. He looked truly wretched and evil, and now that he was powerful enough, he could easily cause a mass atrocity! How could the Great Builder be such a fool as to grant a filthy bloodskin this much power?!

"The effects of the SIGIL can be canceled by myself, the Archseer, or a few other people instantly." Jessica said calmly. "Do not let this new power go to your head. You are not invincible... merely less trashy than before. If you fight against a true Demon Emperor, you will die. As for a Demon Duke? That is up for debate."

Her words did nothing to cool Vex's excitement. She had just told him he had gained the power of a Demon Duke in a single step! To go from Lord to Baron was already the height of his ambition, but to be at the level of the legendary Demon Duke *Bael*?! Vex never imagined such a fate would befall him in all his wildest dreams!

He immediately turned around and dropped to one knee, greeting Jessica with respect.

"Forget the Demon Emperors! I'll follow you forever, you gorgeous, beautiful woman! And I don't even like chicks, so that's saying a lot!"

"That is the appropriate response." Jessica said, unruffled by his words.

She raised an eyebrow as she looked at the others gathered.

"Those who pledge their allegiance to the Divine Empire will receive the same boons. Those who leave will not. As for whether you deserve to be a part of this Empire, that will depend on my assessment of each of you, alongside the Sphinx."

Jason balked. "Hey, I was going to interview them! Where do you get off-"

"Silence!" Jessica shouted, snapping an irritated gaze at him. "Your services are no longer required. Return to your former duties and leave these small, unimportant matters to myself and the Sphinx! Begone!"

Many people were surprised by the lack of respect Jessica showed the man. She didn't seem intimidated by him, and even seemed to look at him as if he was a moron.

But then again, that couldn't be helped. He was always shouting like an idiot, so it was natural nobody took him seriously. Jessica was by far the more proper leader-worthy of the three on stage. Naturally, she started to command more respect.

Jason coughed. He looked around at the people present and muttered something under his breath. "Fine. Whatever. Do what you want. My work here is done anyway! Don't everyone thank me at once!"

With those words only serving to try and save his own ego, the man turned around and vanished, leaving Jessica and Phoebe behind.

A few people in the crowd snickered. It was pretty funny seeing the man storm away defeated like that, beaten by the whims of some random woman. It seemed he wasn't much after all.

"Alright." Jessica said. "The Sphinx and I will begin interviewing people as soon as possible. Who wishes to go first?"

"ME!" Vex immediately shouted. "Me! Definitely me! You won't regret it!!"

Jessica's face fell. She rolled her eyes.

"Very well. You shall be first then, Vex."

"Yesss!" Vex hissed through his teeth.

He was clearly still excited by the changes to his body. Nobody could blame him.

Before long, the crowd dispersed, and people sat down to await entry into the interviews with the Sphinx and Great Builder. These would surely take a long time, but they were necessary to assess the trustworthiness of those present.

Phoebe looked over at where Jason had stood not long before. She chuckled under her breath.

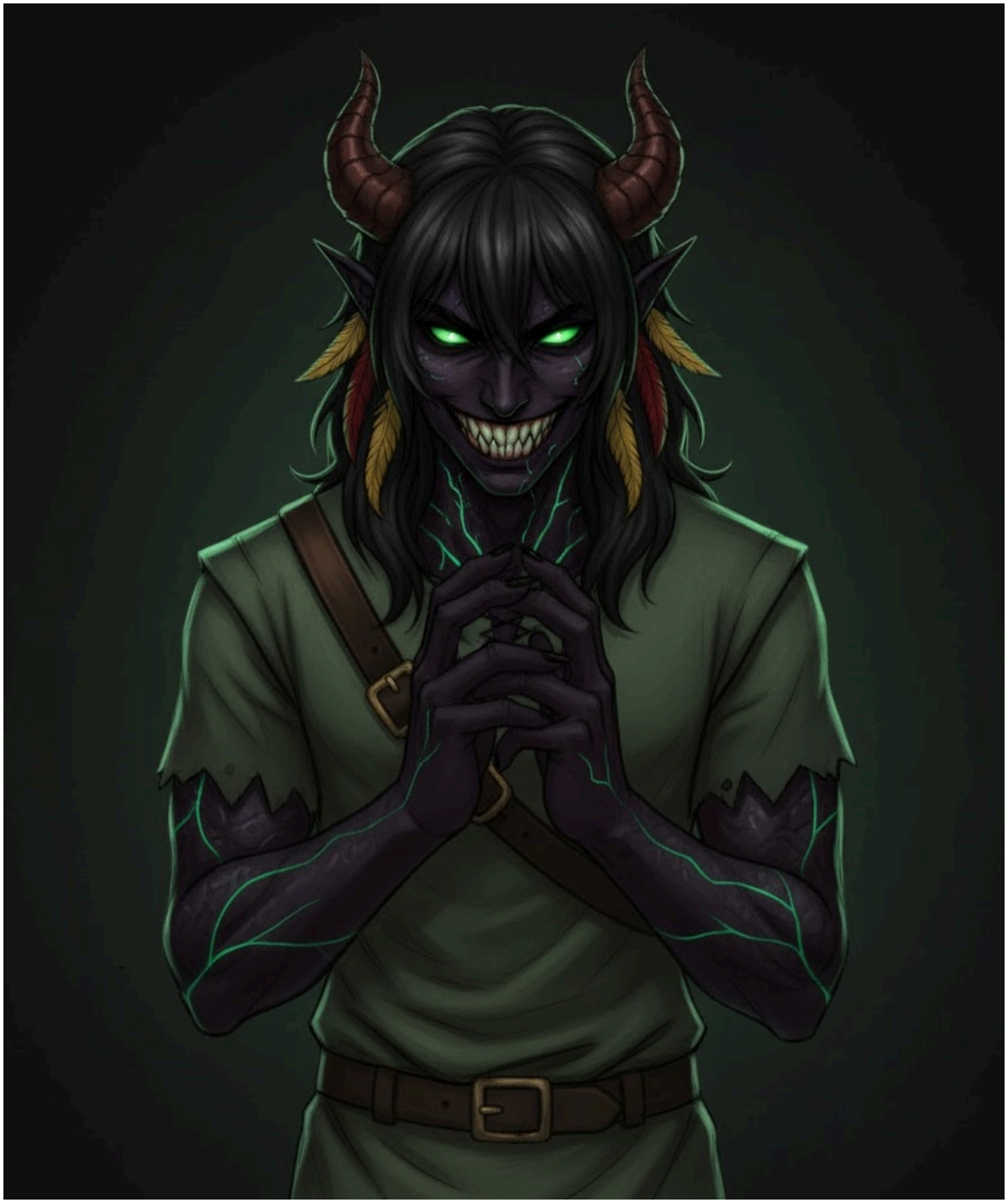
"A funny young man playing funny tricks..."

Author Note:

This is Vex! Him and his empowered form, to show off the changes to his physique!

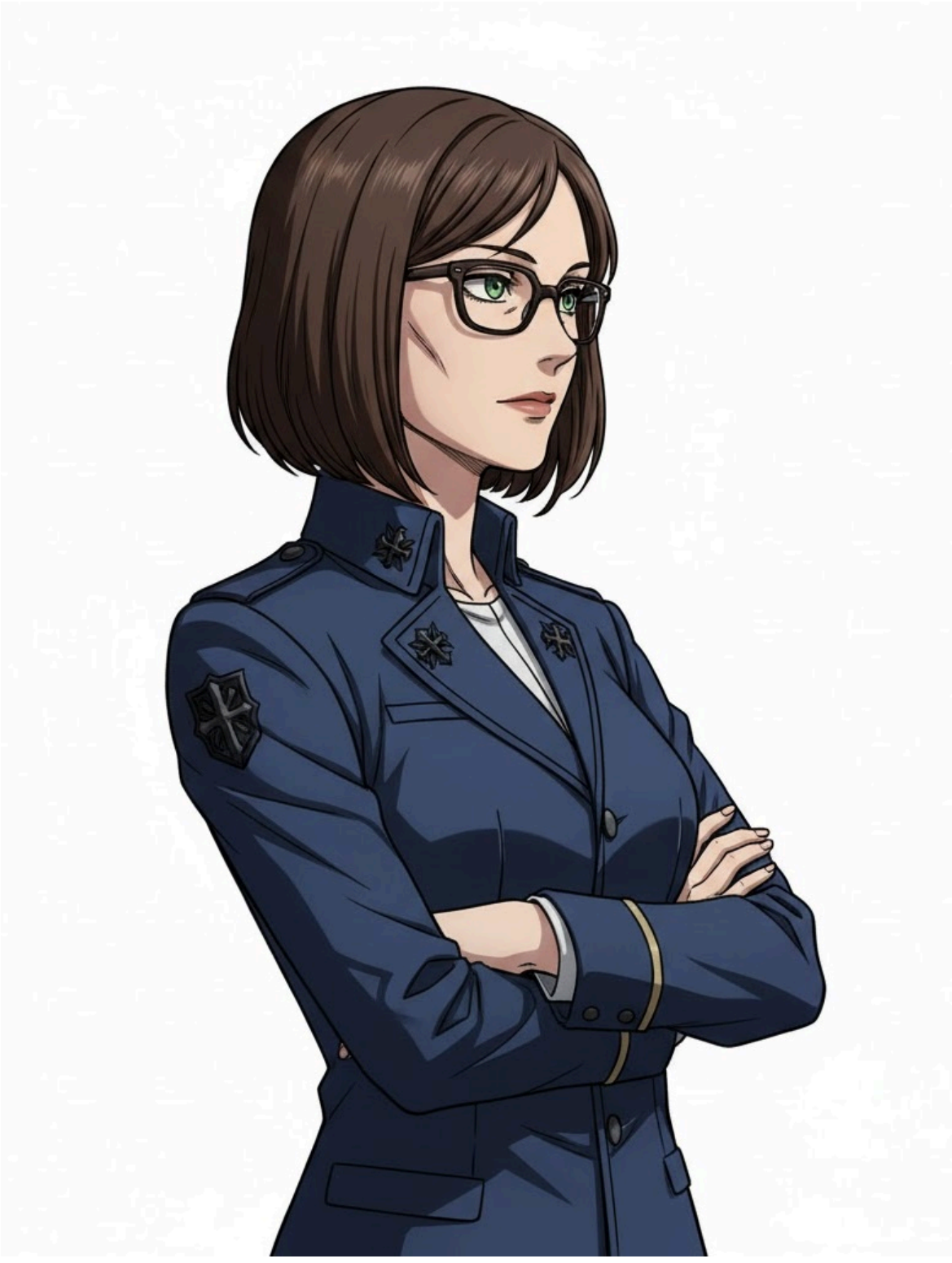
Vex's Base Form

Vex SIGIL Form



Also, here is the angel Almar

And Jessica Harper!



Part 712: Grief

January 29th, 2021. Argent, Aevum.

Daisy was training with a bo staff by herself, thwacking it against a lifelike combat training dummy. The dummy moved surprisingly agilely, animated by her father's magic. It was neither dumb nor intelligent, merely fighting with the single-minded purpose of learning its opponent's movements and attempting to counteract them.

It was a faceless, heavily padded dummy, which was great because when it struck Daisy's body, she didn't end up severely injured or hospitalized. It also meant she could beat it as hard as she wanted with her staff, though that was proving difficult. It learned how to anticipate her moves faster than she learned from it.

Daisy was not great at wielding weapons in melee combat. Her movements were uncoordinated, and she frequently lost her grip on the staff, sending it tumbling to the ground when she tried to spin it up and attack the dummy. As a result, she often got pillowed in the face by the dummy's soft fists, sending her sprawling to the ground.

Daisy rubbed her butt and winced. Even though the Dummy was not intended to seriously hurt her, she had fallen on her ass several times, and her muscles were no longer in peak shape. She held up a palm.

"Let's take a break."

The dummy obediently lowered its fists and slumped forward slightly, returning to its energy-saving state. Daisy cracked her back and stretched, feeling the blood flow through her limbs.

She attempted to heal herself, but her magic failed. She frowned. Her father had supposedly used his Wordsmithing to give her full control of her magic, but it kept flickering on and off like a poorly screwed-in lightbulb. She wasn't sure why this particular power was so unreliable, but it was especially frustrating because she had planned to return home and heal the body of her adopted sister, Anya.

Anya had been in a wheelchair since she was old enough to crawl. She sometimes had enough strength to get up and walk around, but those instances were rare, and made her

sadder than if she couldn't walk at all. She suffered from a compromised immune system, so she couldn't leave the house. Doing so might kill her.

Thus, Anya lived her entire life cooped up indoors, feeling like a bird trapped in a cage. She was always sullen and somber, a fact that made Daisy quietly weep on several occasions.

"I'll have to ask dad to heal Anya." Daisy muttered to herself. "It should be doable for him. If not, maybe he can befriend Aunt Samantha in this timeline?"

Daisy scratched her chin. She chewed her lip thoughtfully as she considered the likelihood. She had yet to interact with Emperor Belial, but she doubted her auntie was a complete villain at this point in history. She must still have a soft spot for children...

As Daisy stood there, catching her breath and recovering from her training routine, she felt a presence appear behind her. She turned around and broke into a smile.

"Daddy! How are you doing?"

Jason smiled back at her, but his expression was a little off. "I'm fine, sweetheart. I came here to check on you."

Daisy nodded. After the incidents with Heaven's Daughter and Nadia, her father had clearly been dealing with a profound sense of guilt. He didn't need to tell his daughter about it for her to realize. She knew her father wasn't in the best headspace, but she also didn't know how to broach the subject. She still felt like he and her had a long way to go before they became truly 'close'.

"I just finished sparring with the dummy you made for me." Daisy said, casually gesturing behind herself with her thumb. "How about you, dad? Are you doing... okay?"

Jason continued to smile, but his eyes lowered a little. Daisy easily noticed the sadness he was trying to hide. He wasn't doing a good job at it.

"Dad?" Daisy asked quietly.

Jason lightly bit his lower lip. He took a step toward her, then held out his arms.

"Come here, honey." Jason said.

Daisy nodded. She stepped toward him, and then... they embraced.

Daisy hugged her father. There didn't seem to be any reason behind why he wanted to hug her, but she could tell... this hug meant a lot to him. It was the first time they had

hugged like this since he awakened his memories...

Daisy closed her eyes. She buried her face in her father's neck. Even though he physically was the age of a brother, he still had the bearing of a parent. She felt calm and safe in his arms.

"I love you, sweetheart..." Jason said quietly. "I don't say that enough."

Daisy opened her eyes. Held in her father's arms, she couldn't see his face, but now she realized his mental state was worse than she had imagined. He wasn't acting like himself at all.

"Dad... what's going on?" Daisy asked, carefully pulling away from him a little, just enough that she could look into his eyes. She checked and found this was her real father, and not a Dronesmith.

Jason didn't meet his daughter's gaze. He looked at the floor.

"It's... it's about your mom." Jason said quietly.

Daisy's heart fell into her shoes. She looked at her father with a sinking feeling.

"M-mom? What happened to her? Dad, what happened?! Don't tell me Bahamut killed..."

Jason blinked. He lifted his head and looked at his daughter in surprise.

"What? No. No, of course not. I'm sorry, honey. I'm not using my words well. I just... I'm a little out of sorts right now. Your mom..."

He hesitated.

"...I went to Bahamut's city. I found her. I forced her to release all of her slaves. Then I had your mother kill Bahamut and inherit the power of the Sphinx."

Daisy stared at her father in shock. "You went without me? But why?! I thought when the time was right, you and me were going to save mom together!"

Jason took a step back. He let go of Daisy, allowing his arms to fall to his side.

"Honey... nobody... nobody wants to save your mother as much as I do. But. But. The woman I saved... she's your mother's younger self. She doesn't know you. Or me. She doesn't remember the future. She has no idea you're her daughter, or I'm her husband. As far as she's concerned, we're complete strangers."

Daisy stared at him intently. "So what? Are you saying you left me out because I would just overwhelm her?! Dad, that's my mom you're talking about! Your wife!"

"She's not my wife, and she's not your mother." Jason said sternly. "Not right now she isn't. I didn't bring you along because I believed you wouldn't be able to stop yourself from talking about the future."

"I can control myself just fine!" Daisy shouted. "This is unfair! Dad, why are you acting like this?? Just use your Wordsmithing! Make her remember the future! Then she'll be my mom again!!"

Jason fell silent. He closed his eyes and lowered his head.

"...Do you think that option didn't occur to me, Daisy? It was the very first thing I thought of doing when I realized Phoebe was still alive in this timeline."

Jason turned away from his daughter. He wandered over to the side of the room and sat down on a bench, leaning heavily forward in a posture of defeat.

Daisy hesitated. She eventually walked over and sat beside him.

"Then, why didn't you do it?" Daisy asked, bewildered. "Dad, why not give mom back her memories?"

It took a long ten seconds before Jason was able to muster up an answer.

"Daisy. I'm a failure." Jason said softly. "Everything I touch turns to ashes. Countless people died because of me. Because of my incompetence. I'm afraid that if I recklessly try to retrieve my wife, I'll only cause even more harm to her."

"How can restoring her memories cause harm?" Daisy pressed. "You're not making sense."

"I've thought about it a lot." Jason said under his breath. "I've realized that there's a lot of ways trying to turn this younger version of Phoebe into the one we lost could backfire. Just pause for a moment, Daisy. Cool your emotions. Think rationally."

Daisy fell silent. She took a deep breath and tried to calm her heart, like her father requested.

"...Okay." Daisy said. "Tell me what could go wrong, dad."

Jason forced out a weak smile. He rested his palm on his daughter's knee and gave it a reassuring squeeze.

"Imagine for a moment that I used my magic to give your mother her memories from the future." Jason said. "Did you know Hope did the same thing? He put Amelia's memories inside the mind of another woman."

"Amelia?" Daisy asked, scrunching up her face. "Do I know her?"

Jason thought for a moment.

"It's been a long time. I don't remember. If you ever did speak with her, it couldn't have been more than once or twice." Jason said. "But that doesn't matter. Amelia was a woman I loved before your mom. After I made your uncle Hope by cloning myself, Hope was distraught because he had lost the life I was then living. Without Phoebe around, he became desperate and tried to create a copy of our first love, Amelia, by putting her memories inside another woman."

"Did it work?" Amelia asked.

"No." Jason answered. "Because the woman was not Amelia, her mind rejected the memories. Keep in mind, this woman, Annette, was in love with Hope and asked him to change her appearance and mind to become Amelia. She loved him enough to voluntarily give up her identity and become Amelia. But it didn't matter. Annette's psyche still rejected those memories, and she became a tortured soul, torn between two personas."

"Okay, I can see that." Daisy admitted. "But mom is mom! Her memories from the future are still HER memories! You can just implant them without worrying she'll become someone else. It's not like you're putting Aunt Samantha's memories in mom's body!"

Jason shook his head. "I thought about that too. Daisy, imagine for a moment that I made you watch a video that showed you images and sounds and smells from someone I claimed was your future self. Even if you believed those were your memories from the future, would you be that person? Would you *become* your future self?"

Daisy scratched her head. "Well... I don't think so...?"

"It almost certainly wouldn't work out." Jason said. "I can't just replace her memories with those of future Phoebe. I can't alter the essence of who she is now. At best, I can insert the memories of who she was into her mind. But doing that would only feel to her like she was seeing the memories of another person. Attempting to forcefully overwrite her current memories with the ones from our original timeline would ultimately result in

an Amelia-Annette situation. Your mother would start suffering from psychosis, questioning who she really was."

Jason turned his head to look at his daughter.

"Do you want your mother to suffer like that, Daisy?"

Tears welled up in Daisy's eyes. She pressed her fingers against her eyes and hiccuped. "No... no, daddy... I just... I want my mom back... I want her back."

Jason nodded hollowly. He reached his arm out and wrapped it around her back, then pulled her close.

"I know you do, baby. So do I. I would give my life to bring Phoebe back."

Jason swallowed. His throat was dry. Raw. Tears welled up in his eyes. His body shook as he felt all the suppressed emotions starting to boil up.

"God... god, I want Phoebe back." Jason whispered, squeezing his eyes shut. "I want her back so badly. She's right there. *Right there*, honey. I could reach out and kiss her. But it wouldn't be right. And most importantly... I don't deserve your mother. That's what hurts the most."

Daisy sniffled. She puled away from her father and looked at him with puffy red eyes. "Dad... what are you saying? You don't deserve her? Where are you even getting that from?!"

"Your mom died because of me." Jason said, rubbing his bleary eyes. "Who am I to selfishly try and bring her back just to make myself feel better? Who am I to make a new Phoebe to replace the old one I discarded through my inaction? What right do I have to live happily after killing your mother through my incompetence?"

Daisy gritted her teeth. She felt a deep anger boiling up inside of her.

"What the hell, dad?! Is that the real reason you don't even want to try?! Because you think you're undeserving?! FINE! Maybe that's true! Maybe it IS! But what about me, dad? What about ME?! Why do I have to go without a mother just because you feel guilty?? I had to grow up without parents! I was tortured by scientists, prodded like a lab rat, treated like a toy, and all the while I just wanted my mom and dad to save me!! And now you're holding me back from her just because you feel GUILTY?!"

Daisy grabbed at her hair. She tugged and pulled on it, wanting to rip it out due to her grief and anger. She couldn't stop crying. She wept uncontrollably, and her crying only

made Jason cry harder.

Every word struck him like a hammer. He felt as if he were being ripped in half. Torn between his self-hatred and desire to do good by his little girl.

But how could he satisfy her? Even if he wanted to restore Phoebe to her future self, it was impossible. He wouldn't subject her to the same trauma Annette had suffered.

"I'm sorry." Jason mumbled, sniffling while his shoulders heaved uncontrollably. "Baby, I'm sorry... I just... I don't want to make you cry... but it's all I know how to do. I'm a complete failure, and it's killing me inside."

"God fucking dammit, dad! You're not a failure! You're not!" Daisy screamed, her anger slowly overtaking her anguish. "Why do you keep saying that?! Dad, you time traveled! This is the past, not the future! You can change things, live a better life, save people! You can get mom back and make sure she never dies again! You don't have to shackle yourself to a future that NO LONGER EXISTS!!"

Jason became quiet. His eyes remained tightly closed, his fingers pressed against his eyelids.

A long minute passed.

"You say... the future doesn't exist?" Jason asked softly.

"Then why do I still remember it?" Jason whispered. "How can everything that happened mean nothing?"

His shoulders heaved as he stifled a sob.

"How can I live with all the people who died because of me?"

"How can I go on knowing that your mother ultimately died?"

"What does it matter if I resurrect her here? I will always know I failed her."

"Even if I perfectly restore her, how can I face her, knowing I left Timothy behind? How can I look her in the eyes and tell her I abandoned our son? Your *brother*?"

Jason pressed his face into his hands. He wept, heaving long hard sobs as the pain of his failures crashed down upon him.

"Oh god! God!! I don't know how to go on! I DON'T KNOW!! Everything hurts! Every day, it hurts! I look in the mirror and I want to kill him! I want to rip him a-fucking-part! I hate that piece of shit! I hate him, I hate me, I hate everyone!!"

Daisy stared at her father in silent disbelief. By now, she had realized that her pain was far, far lesser than his. It wasn't inconsequential, but never had she realized until this very moment just how broken Jason had become. His guilt, his grief... she could not fathom just how much pain he had been silently enduring... for her sake.

"Dad... dad, I'm sorry." Daisy mumbled, leaning in closer. "Dad, don't cry... I'm here for you, okay? I'm sorry. I didn't mean to say all those things. Come on, dad, come here... I'm here for you, daddy..."

Daisy carefully wrapped her arms around her father. She set aside her own feelings, realizing that now, he needed her just as much as she needed him.

Jason cried. He sobbed and wept. He wailed uncontrollably, fully breaking down in front of someone for the first time in his entire life.

When he had lost his foster mother and father, Jason had trudged through life in a daze.

When he had realized Amelia was dead, Jason felt only desolation in his heart.

When he thought Daisy had perished, Jason hadn't been able to muster any tears.

When his wife fell, he became barren, unable to feel anything but an abyss.

Only now, after countless years had passed, did he finally release all his emotions into his daughter's embrace.

Daisy felt strange. Her father was supposed to comfort her, but instead, she was comforting him. But this strangeness quickly left her heart. She closed her eyes and rested her cheek atop his head.

Rocking back and forth, ever so gently, Daisy stayed with her father for a full hour. She was mostly quiet, sometimes crying along with him, sometimes only taking in the emotions and thinking about the absurdity of the situation with a joyless smile.

The father and daughter had both suffered terrible traumas. Daisy eventually realized that hers was no greater or lesser than his. He had lost a wife and a son, while she had lost a mother and a brother. Jason might feel personally responsible, but that did not lessen the trauma Daisy had suffered during her childhood. And indeed, her pain was a part of her father's pain, as he blamed himself for what she had endured.

But, eventually, both of their emotions ran their courses. They ran out of tears to cry.

Jason pulled away from his daughter. His expression was wretched, but... releasing all those emotions was a relief. It was as if a dam had burst, allowing everything he hadn't allowed himself to say to now flow freely.

Jason wiped his eyes. He looked at the ground.

For the first time in a long time... he felt better.

Not good. Not *great*. Just 'better.'

Jason summoned some tissues. He handed them to Daisy, then he blew his nose while she blew hers.

After a moment, Jason looked at his little girl. For no reason at all, he faintly smiled, then let out a small laugh.

"Haha..."

"You're laughing?" Daisy asked, slightly astonished.

"It's just... I'm so sorry, honey." Jason said, wiping his tear-stained eyes. "I'm supposed to be the big reliable man, but here I am, blubbering like a baby."

"It's alright, daddy. Everyone needs to cry sometimes. I'm glad you let it all out." Daisy said soothingly. "There's no shame in crying just because you're a man."

Jason caressed his daughter's face. He touched her tenderly, wishing with all his heart he could have done so a thousand more times since she was a child.

"I love you so much, baby girl." Jason said. "I know... I know it hurts. You want to see your mother. You want to make up for all that lost time. But we can't do that, okay? I need you to try and let go. Try and treat her as a normal person, getting to know her step by step. In time, I will introduce the idea to her that we knew each other in the future. I just don't want to overwhelm her right now. Okay? Okay?"

Daisy winced. She nodded slowly, but lowered her eyes.

"Alright, daddy." Daisy mumbled. "I'll try to be strong."

"Good. Good girl." Jason said, leaning forward and kissing her forehead. "I'm going to bring Phoebe here sooner rather than later. I'll let you know beforehand. When she arrives, I'll introduce you as my daughter... so just play that part as best you can."

Daisy felt as if a stake had been driven into her stomach. She squirmed uncomfortably. "Yes, daddy."

Jason cleared his throat. He stood up, then used a Word of Power to refresh himself and Daisy both.

"I... have to get back to work." Jason said. "Sorry I dumped all that on you. But I'm glad you were here for me. We have to be there for each other, because we're all we have left."

"Yeah..." Daisy whispered.

But she didn't believe him.

She still had a mother. One day, Daisy would definitely, definitely hug and kiss her mom and cry in her arms again.

There had to be a way to restore Phoebe to the way she once was. Daisy just didn't know what method she would use yet.

Jason muttered a Word of Power. He vanished from the room, leaving his little girl behind.

Daisy sat on the bench for a while longer. Eventually, she got up, grabbed her bo staff and started sparring with the training dummy again. Only now, this time, she was hitting it much harder than before.

She had a lot of aggression she needed to unleash.

Part 713: Sparring

January 29th, 2021.

A lot was happening in the Milky Way, and more specifically, many seismic events were occurring on Earth.

In less than an hour, Bahamut was deposed and killed. The demons had no idea one of their allies had been eradicated from existence.

And why didn't they? Because they were busy mounting an assault on Heaven. Far earlier than in Jason's original timeline, the demons were launching an attack to pursue their strategic objectives. They didn't monitor Bahamut closely, so they had no way of knowing she was dead.

At the same time, Aevum was rapidly progressing day by day. Four minutes in realspace was one day in Aevum. In the few hours the demons spent taking over Saint Catherine's Monastery and fortifying it into a forward base that could launch a continuous stream of attacks upon Mount Sinai, weeks had already passed inside Aevum.

The demons were not aware of the Wordsmith's actions. But elsewhere in the Sol system, someone else *was* taking notice of the rapidly evolving situation on Earth.

It was a Volgrim ship known as the VLL Scout Class 1175-Monitor. A long and unimportant name for a low-level scouting ship of little importance to the Volgrim Empire. It was equipped with a crude, cheap, barely functional stealth module that was nonetheless countless epochs more advanced than any technology present on Earth. As such, despite being considered a low level and trashy vessel no Volgrim would spare a glance toward, it was nevertheless a serious threat to the people of Earth.

Only a handful of people even knew it was there, and none of them were willing to speak of its existence yet.

Aboard the 1175-Monitor, its crew consisted of 35% Changelings, 50% Technopaths, and a modest complement of Psions.

These were not powerful Psions. In fact, the mightiest one among their ranks was a mere 5th Level Psion known as Nufaris. The rest were at the 4th level, and were only present in a civilian capacity. Nufaris was the commander of the 1175-Monitor, and

possessed the most potent psionic abilities of the crew. Even so, he was not worth mentioning among the billions of superior Psions who towered above him. Until a Psion reached the 6th Level, they were not even a Bottom Cosmic, and countless meatshield grunts like him existed throughout the tertiary of their society.

The Milky Way had hundreds of billions of stars. Those stars had trillions of planets. Those planets had tens of trillions of moons. Cataloging and monitoring all of them was an exhausting job and constantly stretched the military thin. Only the Volgrim knew just how rich with life the Milky Way was, but they still had to be realistic when it came to which planets they deemed worth studying and monitoring.

Earth was an interesting planet. Its technology level was low, but the Volgrim had deployed the 1175-Monitor in orbit of Jupiter and occasionally Saturn in order to keep an eye on Earth from long-range. This was because, due to an unfortunate accident during the Great Wars, a stray ship had been lost elsewhere in the galaxy and crash-landed on Earth some seventy orbital cycles before. This had subsequently caused a massive spike in humanity's technological prowess as secretive military bases studied and proliferated its technology.

The Volgrim were not alarmed. They didn't really care all that much. It had taken their species thousands of years to go from a planet-wide industrial level to traversing the Void in powerful spacecraft. They were so greatly advanced compared to Earth that they could dispatch a single 6th Level Psion to pacify it at any point if it started to look like a threat. Besides that, the ship that had crashed was an ancient escape pod more than a million cycles older than modern Volgrim technology. It was less than trash in their eyes.

Thus, the 1175-Monitor's ultimate purpose was simply to observe and record the progress of human society, making a report to the Founders every decade or so. Nufaris knew his job was benign, so he also knew he was not allowed to take military action without express permission.

Additionally, though Nufaris captained the 1175-Monitor, he was in fact subservient to the Changelings, who had laid claim to Earth's monitoring. He operated under the orders of several high-ranking Changelings only a few positions below the Third Founder, Treyza.

Thus, it was on this seemingly random cycle when Nufaris found himself, as always, feeling cooped up and bored while monitoring Earth's primitive radio transmissions, their

digital infrastructure, and their surface dwellings for important activity.

[Informer Jin.] Nufaris said, as he glanced at a readout on the ship's Bridge. [We have noticed unusual demonic activity near the angel's World Entrance. It seems they intend to mount an attack on Mount Sinai.]

Informer Jin, a 5th Level Changeling and the highest ranked military member on the ship, was standing nearby, casually monitoring radio-waves emanating from Earth. It slowly turned its head to look at the holographic display of Earth.

"This one has noticed the movements of the demons. This one does not believe the situation warrants a report to the Planetary Oversight Commission."

[Of course not. I would not presume to bother the Commission over such a minor matter.] Nufaris said. [However, I believe we should take a closer look at the battle unfolding. It would be a good opportunity to collect intelligence on the combat capabilities of the demons and angels.]

Informer Jin's face remained placid. It did not place much value on the happenings on Earth outside a vague interest in studying the biology of the many different species living there. Earth just so happened to be the most diversely populated world in the galaxy, with hundreds of Sentient species and sub-species. Almost every other world had one or two major life forms that dominated the lower life forms... but Earth had hundreds competing for domination. It was truly bizarre.

For Jin, studying the biology of these cross-breeding species, as well as studying their rich and interesting political philosophies proved to be quite engrossing. But observing a war and its tactics were not too interesting to the Informer. Jin did not place much value on ugly, low-level battles between mere mud-dwellers.

"Do you believe this to be a good use of our assets?" Observer Jin asked dryly.

[We need not go overboard.] Nufaris quickly said. [I suggest we dispatch a 4th Level Psion to observe the battle more closely. Someone specializing in stealth would be ideal. Have them bring along recording devices as well.]

Jin contemplated the idea for a long minute. Then, it waved its hand lazily.

"Very well. You may dispatch one junior to observe more closely. The humans are growing more competent at scanning their airspace for anomalies by the day. We do not wish to draw attention to our Empire."

[Do you believe we will be able to keep these primitives at arm's length for much longer?] Nufaris questioned. [The vessel that crashed on the North American continent has surely given the mud-dwellers assurances that they are not alone in the universe.]

Observer Jin snorted through its nostril. "If you worry that these humans are only just recently becoming aware of the existence of alien life, then allow this one to remind you of the existence of the angels. They are life-forms which did not originate on Earth. In fact, this one personally believes they may be from a precursor civilization that predates the Volgrim."

Nufaris stared at Jin. His expression contorted slightly.

[Older than the Volgrim... do you have any proof of such claims? Their technology is so primitive that I find this idea laughable. How could a civilization older than our own have failed to evolve past ours for so long?]

"This one's theories have not found purchase among the High Changelings." Jin admitted. "Spying on the angels inside their hidden dimension has proven nearly impossible. This one has unsuccessfully sought permission to observe the inside of 'Heaven' so as to better comprehend the history of the angels. Unfortunately, the Commission does not see eye to eye with this one and have refused to allow any study that might contaminate the planet's political situation."

Nufaris's eyes flashed with insight. [So... you wish to scout the interior of Heaven?]

[This one would like to do so, but the Commission will not allow this one to slip any drones through the dimensional membrane hidden inside Mount Sinai.]

Nufaris stood up from his commanding chair. He casually sauntered over to Observer Jin, his figure towering a full head above the diminutive Changeling. He crossed his arms and smiled cunningly with his eyes.

[Observer Jin, it seems we will be able to fulfill multiple strategic objectives at once. I shall travel to the planet myself. My stealth capabilities are second to none among other 5th Level Psions. I will quietly uncover the history you seek, and you will create a cover story for me.]

Jin's expression shifted slightly. It vaguely appeared to frown.

"This decision will be criticized severely." Jin warned. "If you do not produce results, you are likely to be court-martialed."

[Then I suppose I should not return empty-handed.] Nufaris mused. [With your permission, I will head out immediately.]

Jin nodded its head. "Go in peace. Return victorious. Do not interfere with Earth's matters. Do not provoke a diplomatic incident."

[I contemplate, and I comprehend.] Nufaris said, bowing at the waist.

Without further ado, he left the Bridge, headed to an airlock, and departed the vessel. He flew toward Earth, where before long he would begin a reconnaissance mission that would soon change the trajectory of the Milky Way's future...

Jason stepped into a private training gymnasium inside Aevum. The sounds of swords clanging rang out across the room, drawing his attention. There, he found Nadia sparring with an unexpected partner... not one of the training dummies, but Heaven's Daughter, wearing her full armor and keeping her face covered.

Nadia's movements were swift and fierce. Catherine had centuries worth of training and battle experience, so she was visibly shocked when a mere child was able to keep up with her and learn how to fight with a sword in record time. The longer Nadia and Catherine clashed, the more Nadia became capable of turning the tables on her senior.

Clang, clang, shing!

Their swords collided in a fury. Jason stood in the doorway for several seconds just watching them before he finally slammed the door shut.

That loud noise startled both girls, causing them to take a step back and look in his direction.

"Jason..." Nadia said, giving him a strange look. Her clothes were sticky with sweat from her workout. She quickly turned and grabbed a towel, mopping herself down.

Catherine's body was hidden behind her armor, so Jason did not know if she was sweating just as badly. He didn't bother to ask.

"Jason. Excellent timing." Catherine said, striding over to meet him. "I was just sparring with your protege over here. Miss Nadia is an extremely impressive combatant."

"I can see that." Jason said with a smile. "Are both of you adapting well to your RealitySims?"

He couldn't see Catherine's face, but Jason seemed to sense a smile in her voice. "Oh, yes. It has been a wonderful experience. I now feel as though my former brain was trapped in a quagmire of molasses, while my new one is an Olympic sprinter growing ever faster as time passes."

Nadia walked over. She nodded at Catherine while breathing heavily, then smiled at Jason. "The RealitySim was an excellent choice for me. It has integrated amazingly with my powers."

"Oh yeah? In what way exactly?" Jason asked.

"As I fight with Heaven's Daughter, I save all of her fighting styles and techniques inside my RealitySim. She does the same with my moves, but my cerebral abilities allow me to much more quickly comprehend her fighting capabilities and adapt them for my own uses."

Catherine turned her head to look at the young woman. "I must admit, I have grown envious of Nadia's powers. My abilities are, of course, quite potent, but her mental powers are disgustingly efficient when combined with her MindCore. I do not believe it will take me more than another three or four days before I can no longer surprise her at all unless I invent new novel weapons with my magic. Even if I do, they will be outside the scope of our sparring, since they would threaten her life."

Nadia waved her hand casually. "Don't flatter me too much. You've obviously been going easy on me. If you wielded your full arsenal, I'd be dead a hundred times over."

Catherine didn't counter Nadia's words. Instead, she turned to look at Jason.

"It is my understanding that you intend to turn Nadia into an inventor. Do you believe that is the wisest course of action?"

Jason blinked. "I'm not going to force her down that path or anything, but it certainly seemed the smartest choice to me. Why?"

"Because." Catherine said, her tone serious. "I think you are greatly underestimating just what a frightening warrior Nadia could become. She can quickly learn and master any fighting style in months, weeks, days, or even hours. If you were to train her to become a warrior, and if you outfitted her with proper armor and some of those support abilities you've shown me, she could easily become one of the strongest combatants on Earth."

Jason rubbed his chin thoughtfully. "I see what you're saying. And Nadia, if you want to go down that path, I'll certainly offer you my full support. But I don't think it's the right decision."

"Why not?" Catherine asked. She seemed a little upset he would immediately reject her. "Doesn't Earth need as many warriors as it can muster?"

Jason started to open his mouth, but surprisingly, Nadia was the one who butted in.

"I'm sorry, Heaven's Daughter, but Jason is right. It would be unwise for me to devote myself to becoming a physical powerhouse, even if my abilities seem perfect for it. That is because Jason plans to create many different types of combat assets. What he lacks right now are Thinkers who can help him quickly design new types of weapons, armor, spaceships, energy production facilities, and other such things that will rapidly advance humanity's global strength."

She continued. "In your eyes, the demons represent an existential threat to humanity. But to Jason, they are only the first enemy we must defeat. He has his eyes on a much more dangerous foe."

Catherine's head twitched. "You're talking about the aliens watching over Earth?"

"Yes." Nadia admitted. "Has Jason told you about them?"

"Only a little." Catherine said, turning her helmet to stare at Jason.

"I'll tell you before you leave and head back to Heaven." Jason said. "It simply wasn't important for you to know about right now."

He expected to get at least a little of an earful from Catherine, but she simply backed down and nodded. "Alright. If you do or don't tell me, that's fine too. I trust you."

Jason's mouth fell slightly open and he gave Catherine a strange look. Nadia also surreptitiously glanced at Catherine out of the corner of her eye.

Wasn't she trusting Jason a little... too easily?

But then again... Nadia was no different. If Jason asked her to throw herself into a fire, she'd barely hesitate. Only she knew the depths of her feelings for the man before her...

"Ahem." Jason said, clearing his throat to try and defuse a bit of the tension in the air. "Don't worry, I'm not trying to keep this a secret from you. I don't actually care if anyone knows. The problem is, if the Volgrim find out that *we* know, it will potentially create a

catastrophe. In an ideal world, they will think we're oblivious to their existence for another several decades or longer, giving us time to create counter-measures to them. But if we're unlucky or make mistakes, we might alert them early. We cannot defeat the Volgrim as we are now. We have to delay for as long as possible."

That explanation satisfied Catherine. She folded her gauntlets over her waist and nodded. "I understand. The situation seems quite volatile."

After a momentary pause, Catherine spoke again. "Jason, regarding what we spoke about last time, I've chosen a fellow Lazarite I think would work best as my assistant. If you can bequeath her a MindCore, specifically a GenesisFrame like yours, then she will be able to assist me greatly in the creation of further weapons and technology for the Lazarites."

"Sure thing." Jason said. "You were planning to leave within the next week and return to Heaven, right? I can give one Lazarite an upgrade in a day or two. Why don't you tell me who they are now so I can bring them here and make them comfortable?"

"Certainly." Catherine said, before waving her hand and using her light magic to conjure a shockingly realistic light-based puppet of a different Lazarite Jason hadn't seen before. Her entire body, clothing, and hair were golden, but the detail on her face was no less impressive than any ancient Roman statue that had lost its color to the ages. She looked to be an older woman in her forties, with lightly tossed curly hair, wearing a cute bonnet on her head. Her attire made it seem as if she had lived somewhere around the time of the early 20th century.

"Her name is Helen." Catherine explained. "She is one of the newer angels in Heaven, though a few generations removed from the last billion new entrants. She isn't considered a figure worthy of note, and I doubt anyone will be keeping a close eye on her, especially if you're only going to bring her into Aevum for a half-hour of Realspace time."

Jason nodded. "If you think she's trustworthy, I can bring her here. Let me see if I can find her first. **Locate.**"

Jason closed his eyes. His soul separated from his body as he locked onto the target angel's signature. He vanished from Aevum and crossed the galaxy in the blink of an eye, diving toward the Earth.

For the briefest of moments, Jason's soul paused. He looked out across the blackness of space, feeling as if he might have sensed something near Earth's orbit. But after looking

for a while, he didn't uncover any hidden assets.

"Hmm." Jason grunted.

He dove down, down, down into Earth's atmosphere, pierced the membrane of a hidden dimension, and tore into Heaven itself.

Here, he had to proceed with caution. He shielded his soul by turning his illusory self as transparent and ghostly as possible. It meant that if someone attacked him, they would be able to snuff out his life in an instant, but it also made him much harder to detect. Jason doubted even a manipulation-master like Raphael would sense his errant soul unless he drew within a hundred feet of the old man.

And so, Jason slowly lowered himself from the sky. He picked out Helen's soul signature with ease thanks to Catherine's direction, but he still paused to look around Heaven. Every angel seemed to be in a hurry to don their armor, wield their weapons, and psych themselves up for war. The Lazarites were bored beyond reason after being forbidden from leaving Heaven since their deaths, so they were by far the most eager to fight. But even among them, many Lazarites were quite fond of the quiet and serene life they had been living.

Heaven was far bigger now than in the Ancient Era. It had grown to envelope the entire Earth in a spatial bubble, and held ample living space for the tens of billion of angels living here now. Many human-based structures had been designed and erected with heavenly materials, causing the brutalist designs of the modern era to be contrasted with the glowing and beautiful crystalline walls favored by the angels. It made it seem as if each of Heaven's main cities were shining with bright light, visible from great distances.

Jason slowly lowered into one of the buildings. He found Helen sitting in an apartment complex that was barely decorated and quite dull. She had many books on her shelves, and was reading one while ignoring the world outside. It seemed she was an avid bookworm and held little to no interest in the coming assault by the demons.

After making sure Helen was alone, Jason nodded. His soul turned gaseous, and he dispersed it, reappearing back inside his body.

When he opened his eyes, Jason jerked his head back. Nadia and Catherine were standing barely two feet away, their helmet and face weirdly close to his!

"???" Jason made a weird noise as he took a step back. Nadia blushed and also took a step back, while Catherine's expression remained a mystery.

"Apologies." Catherine quickly said, lowering her head. "I feared for a moment that you might have died. Your body became as still as a corpse."

"Oh." Jason said, relieved they weren't trying to sneak kisses while he wasn't home. "That happens sometimes when I use my abilities. Anyway, I found Helen. She's alone right now, so I'm going to bring her here."

"Please do." Catherine said.

Jason paused. "Well, I wouldn't want to frighten her. Nadia, why don't you leave for a while? Heaven's Daughter and I will greet Helen, and I can keep you and the other people's identities here a secret until I determine her mindset."

Catherine turned to look at Nadia. Nadia twirled her hair around her finger and smiled sheepishly.

"Well, if you want me to leave because you don't want me seeing Heaven's Daughter's real face... um. Actually. I kind of already know who she is... Catherine."

Catherine flinched. Her reaction was visible even despite the armor covering her body.

"You- how do you know my name? Don't tell me you pieced my identity together with that mental power of yours?"

Nadia took a step back and held out her palms apologetically. "No, no, it's not like that. Um. You see, when Jason created my MindCore, he trapped me in a time loop by accident..."

"You did mention that, yes." Catherine said sternly.

"Jason's other self inside the simulation had all of his memories. I learned who you were from him back then." Nadia said, lowering her eyes to the floor while feeling somewhat ashamed.

"Oh. I see. Then why didn't you tell me sooner?" Catherine pressed.

"I thought you wanted to keep your identity a secret, and I didn't know what sort of person you were. I am sorry for deceiving you." Nadia apologized. "I wasn't going to tell anyone without your permission."

Catherine heaved a sigh. Realizing her deception was now pointless, she motioned with her hand and caused her light armor to disperse, revealing her true appearance for the first time that day. She didn't seem too bothered, and simply shrugged helplessly. "Raphael always told me to keep my identity a secret for fear the demons would seek my assassination. But it seems I have been failing to do so for a long time now."

Nadia's eyes sparkled as she looked at Catherine. "Wow... you're really pretty. I didn't expect someone as cool as you to also be so effortlessly beautiful. You could be a model in a magazine..."

"I have no interest in such things. But thank you for the compliment." Catherine said. "Now, Jason, you might as well just bring Helen here. It's fine if she meets Nadia too."

Jason threw his hands up. "Sure! That works for me too. Give me one moment..."

After taking time to clear his mind, Jason reached out with his senses, and uttered a Word of Power.

"**Retrieve.**"

Part 714: Reunited

January 29th, 2021.

Helen laid on her bed in her apartment in Heaven. She had heard that a great battle was soon to be fought, but her daddy raised her proper and she knew the battlefield was no place for a woman. As such, she left such affairs to the brave men in Heaven and some of the more exotic women who didn't have the same proper sense that she did. Queers, the whole lot of them.

She lovingly cradled a book she'd read many times during her life; Jules Verne's *Around the World in Eighty Days*. It had been published only a few decades before she was born, and her mother had read it to her many nights before bed. Helen was quite fond of the story it told, as she had always wanted to travel around the world she was older.

Ah, but then came the Great War, and the Second Great War. Two terrible events almost back to back that ruined global politics and killed tens of millions of people. Luckily, Helen had endured, and before she died, she did get to travel around the world, visiting Italy, Greece, China, Japan, and even India!

These days, she was all sorts of cooped up. Because of the Archangels' decree, low level Lazarites like herself were not permitted to leave Heaven except on special missions, and those who did had their movements closely monitored. Helen had taken to staying inside Heaven and traveling around its vast, world-spanning territory instead. It wasn't nearly as diverse a realm as Earth, but there were all sorts of interesting people there too.

And after a few decades, she had settled into a simpler routine of maintaining her apartment gardens, reading books, and fantasizing about someday returning to Earth to explore it until there was nothing left to see.

It was on this day, the day the demons had begun to attack Mount Sinai, that something strange happened. A shining light engulfed Helen's body, and before she could react, she found she was no longer inside her apartment!

She had materialized inside what appeared to be a mostly empty school gymnasium. It appeared much more modern than the one she had used when she was a child, but it was recognizable nonetheless.

Helen wanted to stand up and take account of her surroundings, but she found that she was already standing, even though she had no idea when that had happened. She looked to her left, and she looked to her right.

On her left there stood two humans. A teenage boy with blonde hair and blue eyes, and a pretty girl with curly brown hair and deep green eyes.

To her right was someone she recognized immediately. Helen was most surprised by the fact that Lady Catherine was here, outside of her armor, in front of these strangers!

"Heaven's Daughter..." Helen said, bewildered. "You, um, you're not hiding your face? No, rather, where are we? What's going on?"

"It's fine, Helen. You can just call me Catherine here." Catherine replied. "To answer your question, this young man is the new Hero. He is the successor of the Heroic Aura, and his name is the Archseer."

Helen widened her eyes. She looked at the young man with renewed interest, now taking much clearer note of his distinct blonde hair and blue eyes.

"Ohh, goodness dickens, so he is! Look at this young child! A Hero, you say?"

Jason scratched his cheek self-consciously. Helen looked to be in her late 40s or perhaps her early 50s, but he was definitely older than her. He decided not to correct her for now.

"I'm Jason, and this is Nadia." Jason said, gesturing to the woman beside him. "Catherine tells me you are a good friend of hers."

Helen blushed at his words. "Me? A friend of Catherine's? Oh, I would never presume! We simply share a few things in common, that's all! Miss Catherine is the blood sister of one of humanity's Heroes, but me? I merely lucked out and married one! We can't be said to be in the same league."

Jason blinked. "What's that? You married a Hero? Who?"

Helen glanced at Catherine. "You didn't tell the boy? You silly-willy! I thought that was why you brought me here, just to embarrass me!"

Helen clicked her tongue, then did a little curtsy. "I doubt you've heard of me, Mister Jason. I'm Helen Whittaker. Many years ago, when I was still young, pretty, and before I was an angel, I was married to the love of my life, Harold Whittaker. He was humanity's last Hero."

Jason's eyes widened in shock. "You're Harold's wife?!"

"Indeed." Helen said, bobbing her head with a sweet smile. "Unfortunately, I passed before Harold did, and he never came to Heaven as an angel. I've long given up hope on seeing him again..."

Her expression turned forlorn, as did Catherine's. Nadia looked like she wanted to console Helen, but Jason...

"Harold?" Jason repeated. "Harold Whittaker? He's your husband?"

Helen nodded. "Yes. It seems you've heard his name before?"

Jason looked from face to face of each of the three women, then scratched his head.

"Heard of him? I know him! Harold's still alive! Well, not exactly alive, but he's living in his Heroic Artifact! You didn't know?"

Helen's face lit up like a Christmas tree. "R-really?! Oh, Saint Mary and Elizabeth! Harold is alive? Do you know where he is? Could I see him?!"

It wasn't originally in Jason's plans, but seeing the joy on the woman's face, he couldn't deny her.

"Sure. He lives here, actually. Moved him in a few weeks back. Why don't you three follow me and we'll pay the old guy a visit."

Helen started shaking with excitement. Jason could have teleported everyone directly to Harold's house, but he didn't want to reveal any powers in front of her unnecessarily, since he wasn't sure how trustworthy she was. He also didn't exactly want to lead another person right through Aevum's streets, but compared to using his Wordsmithing directly, it seemed the lesser of two wrongs.

As such, Jason led Helen out of the Gymnasium with Catherine and Nadia in tow. They walked through the streets of Aevum, which Catherine had grown a little familiar with, but which Helen had never seen.

The woman's eyes widened multiple times as she gasped, ooh'd, and ahh'd at the incredibly otherworldly sights surrounding her. Beams of light shot up into the sky. A massive tower was erected directly in the center of the city, and it was so tall she could barely believe its size! Naturally she had seen skyscrapers on Earth, but she had never seen a single solitary tower that dominated the landscape around it. The lack of visual competition made the Spire more impressive than it would have otherwise been.

On top of that, there were cubes levitating in the air through unknown means. These cubes flew around, seemingly on important missions, but as for what their purposes were, she had no idea.

As exciting as Aevum was, Helen's thoughts were strongly focused on the knowledge she would soon be seeing her husband again. For the first time in decades, she could see Harold! Talk to him! Maybe even hug and kiss him! She was growing positively giddy at the thought!

Jason led her and the others into a large mansion only five or six blocks from the gymnasium. Located in the southern quadrant of Argent, Harold's estate was large not for his sake, but for the sake of all the animals Jason had moved inside.

The Wordsmith had not realized just how many birds, cats, dogs, bears, and other sentient wildlife had been living around Harold's shack, but he had ultimately relented and created a way for them to travel into Aevum's wildlands to hunt for food as they needed. He had created plenty of infrastructure to feed them automatically, but the predators among them had desired to hunt their food themselves.

It was rather weird. Jason found it odd that these sentient animals would opt to hunt and kill other animals, but he had learned they considered non-sentient animals as lesser beings. Any animals who had not been uplifted by Harold's powers were not considered worthy of any rights to remain alive, and as such they were placed distinctly lower on the food chain.

It wasn't as if Jason could fault them. Humans had known for ages that many types of animals were capable of deep thought, introspection, and even communication. That didn't stop them from killing or even mass-farming them for their various body parts. If anything, humans were far worse due to the fact they had invented corporate slaughterhouses. Harold's animals were much more moral by comparison.

Still, the fact animals capable of speaking had come to such a conclusion left him feeling conflicted. He didn't know how to rectify his thoughts on the matter. Ultimately, he let the matter drop. It wasn't his business, and the best he could do was provide alternate means of sustenance. Perhaps in the future he would try and find a more heavy-handed solution, but he had more pressing concerns weighing on his mind.

When the group entered Harold's estate, Helen's eyes brightened when she spotted a large Doberman laying on a doggy bed not far from the estate's entrance.

"Charlie, is that you? Charlie!! Oh my goodness, I can't believe you're still alive! Come here, young man!"

She trotted over to the dog, who slowly lifted his head and looked up at her with confused eyes.

"Do I... know you... miss?" The dog asked.

After sniffing at Helen's leg, his energy levels rose. The Doberman staggered to his feet and seemed to smile. His tail wagged happily, albeit slowly due to his old age.

"Miss Helen... how is it you? Have I finally died? Are we meeting in... the afterlife?"

"Not the afterlife, you silly boy! I'm an angel, and I've come to Earth from Heaven!" Helen said, completely oblivious to the fact she wasn't on Earth at all. She had no idea what state Earth was in, so for all she knew, it had evolved to a grandly higher state of technology after all these years.

Charlie hopped up a little, trying to use what little energy he had to excitedly lick at Helen's face. "Oh, mother! Mother! It's really you... I never thought I'd get to see you again... holding on for... all these years was... truly worth it..."

Tears fell from Helen's eyes as she hugged the dog gently, trying not to cry. She had long assumed all of her beloved pets had succumbed to old age, but Harold's powers not only elevated their intellect, they had granted the animals greater lifespans as well. Their children and progeny would eventually become stronger and stronger each generation, living longer lives with greater quality of lives as their genetics improved over time.

But these first generation animals did not get to live as long as their children. Being able to see their Mother again before they died was an event nobody expected. Before long, word spread that Helen had returned. Sir Marcus the parakeet flew over, and even that annoying crow came flying over to see her.

"CAWW!! MOTHER'S BACK! THE ONLY GOOD PERSON IN THE WORLD! NOT LIKE UGLY STUPID HERO BOY AND STINKY GIRLS! CAWWW!!"

"Chester, you watch your manners." Helen chided, waggling a finger at the crow. "What have I told you about keeping your rude opinions to yourself?"

The crow paused, then he looked away.

"Sorry, mother!"

He didn't even yell the words. Jason was enlightened.

They made their way further into the house, with Marcus and all the other animals excitedly greeting Helen. It was obvious she had built up a deep relationship with them, and even though she hadn't met many of the younger animals, they knew her because of stories passed down by their parents.

Eventually though, Helen became anxious. She went up the stairs to the third floor, and Jason led her into the main bedroom where more than thirty animals, including the huge bear Jason had seen lounging outside Hideki's cabin, were all resting on the ground, on beds, or even on shelves along the walls.

Helen's eyes darted left and right. She paused and stared blankly.

"Where is he?" Helen asked, bewildered. "Where's Harold?"

"He's over there." Jason said, pointing directly across the room.

On the opposite side from the door, there was a giant old-school television from the 1950's. Its back was facing the door, and its front was facing the large pane-glass window. Helen didn't even recognize it as a television at first due to seeing it from behind.

Confused, she walked over to the television, stepped around its side to look at the front, then froze on the spot. Her eyes widened with a mixture of sadness, happiness, horror, and glee. She was confused for a moment, but she managed to piece together what happened quickly.

"This is Harold's artifact..." Helen whispered, as she looked at the image of an old man on the screen, laying in an easy chair, snoring loudly with his head thrown back. He was completely out of it and hadn't noticed his wife's appearance at all. "He always was... glued to the TV when he got older..."

"Yes." Jason said, smiling at her. He felt a deep warmness in his heart. Seeing this couple reunited reminded him of his own situation with Phoebe, and that felt cathartic to the Wordsmith in a visceral sense.

Helen waved her hand in front of the screen. She tapped the screen, then hissed through her teeth...

"Harold... Harold! Harold! Are you... are you okay? Harold? Can you hear me?"

Harold didn't react to her words. She stared at the screen, feeling overwhelmed with emotions, confused by this unexpected development. Never did she expect her husband

would be living inside a television.

"Father is hard to wake up." Marcus the parakeet said, landing on top of the TV. "If you adjust the knobs, that will do the trick. He's usually a bit grouchy when he wakes up, but I'm sure he won't be once he sees you!"

Helen's eyes brightened. She reached over to touch and twist the oversized dials on the side of the television. After a few seconds, Harold's snoring abruptly stopped. His eyes widened, and he sat up in his chair, flying into a rage.

"Dagnabbit, I told you brats not to touch mah damn dials! Who's fiddlin with 'em?! You'd better fess up, bucko!"

"Harold..." Helen said softly, as tears of joy welled up in her eyes. "It's me. It's Helen. I'm... I'm back!"

She touched the screen, desperately wishing she could reach inside and caress his face lovingly, like she did all those years ago...

Harold looked up at the woman who had woken him up.

His expression didn't lighten. If anything, it became nastier.

"Helen? Helen?! You think I give a got-damn what yer name is, woman?? Damn wimmin, always fiddlin' with stuff they ain't 'sposed to! Keep yer hands off mah boob tube, lady!"

Helen's body shook. "Wha-? Harold, it's me, Helen! Helen, your wife! Don't you remember me?"

"Wife? WIFE?! I ain't got no wife! Stupid broad, you got wax in yer ears?" Harold snapped. "Quit foolin' around and get yer grubby mitts off my teevee, woman! Can't you youngsters let an old man rest in peace? SHEESH!"

Harold sneered angrily at Helen, then he flopped back onto his chair and deliberately spun it around so its back was facing outward.

A full minute passed. Helen stared, frozen speechless, the blood drained from her face. She looked like a ghost that had lost its soul.

"Har... Har... Harold... Harry... you don't... re-re-remember... me?"

Helen staggered backward. Jason quickly reached out to catch her before she could trip and fall. He was just as confused as Helen. He couldn't believe Harold didn't

recognize her. For the briefest moment, he thought maybe Helen had been lying and they never were married, but based on how much she knew about Harold, and the fact all the animals knew her, that seemed unlikely. The most obvious answer was that... Harold had completely forgotten his wife!

Jason had no idea why this had happened. He felt absolutely awful for Helen, who was becoming more and more inconsolable every second. She started blubbering apologies to everyone for wasting their time, mixed with barely concealed sobs of anguish.

For decades, she had lived in Heaven, a heart turned to granite at the prospect of never seeing her beloved husband again. Then she finally got that chance, only for the cruel reality of the situation to rip out her heart, throw it on the ground, and stomp it into paste. She had suffered in Hell, ascended to Heaven, and then fallen right back down to Hell again all in a fifteen-minute period, her emotions and spirit completely shattered. She fell into Jason's arms and began weeping, tears staining Jason's shirt as this new revelation finally broke her spirit.

Catherine came over and tried to comfort Helen. Nadia watched from afar, unsure of what to do.

Jason looked at the side of Harold's television. The old man had already fallen asleep, and was snoring loudly again. It was as if Helen waking him up had just been a minor nuisance he easily rid himself of.

At the same time, every one of Helen's tears cut Jason like a knife. He became stone-faced as he realized... Helen was experiencing the same thing as him.

Jason had lost his wife. When he found her again, she had no knowledge of who he was.

Helen had lost her husband. When she found Harold again, he had no knowledge of who she was.

The parallels were so clear that Jason momentarily found himself dissociating from the situation. He felt like an outside observer watching from before. The situation was so absurd he almost found it comical. Was it possible the Creator was pulling the strings of reality as some sort of sick joke? Was he playing the worst prank ever on Jason, and now Helen too?

Jason blinked his eyes. He felt dizzy, yet continued to hug Helen while she sobbed. He looked at Catherine, and she met his gaze. It was clear that Catherine felt distressed for what Helen was going through, but she had no idea of the thoughts going through Jason's head.

Carefully, Jason helped Helen to her feet. He assisted the sobbing woman in leaving the room, where they went outside to get some fresh air. After thinking for a moment, Jason asked Nadia and Catherine to give him and Helen some space.

Once those two went back inside and Jason sat on a bench with Helen, her crying lessened, but it was obvious she had been hurt deeply enough that the knife plunged into her heart would leave a wound that could never be healed.

"Helen..." Jason said softly. "I'm so sorry. I didn't know this would happen."

"It's... nnn... it's not your fault..." Helen sniffled, wiping her long white sleeves across her eyes. "I should have known... he must have caught the dementia... the Alzheimer's... he was getting worse before I passed. I just... I didn't know it would be this... bad..."

Jason swallowed heavily. He never knew his own grandparents, but he'd had a few friends with older relatives who suffered from the cognitive degeneration induced by dementia and Alzheimer's. He knew it was a disease that would bring about brief spurts of memory loss, followed by the eventual and complete decline of their mental faculties.

It was a tragic disease, one that turned a person's most beloved friends and family into strangers.

Fate had slapped Helen cruelly across the face.

Jason squeezed Helen's hand. He looked up into the black sky, with the artificial sun failing to light up a bright-blue atmosphere like on Earth. If Helen were not so distracted, she would have recognized that the sky was 'wrong' almost immediately, but she hadn't.

"I lost my wife." Jason said quietly. "And when I found her, she had forgotten who I was. I know, at least somewhat, what you're going through. Unlike my situation, I think I can help you heal Harold and make him whole again. So don't cry, Helen. I know it hurts to see him like that, but I'll get in contact with my Hero friends. I know a few people who can definitely, definitely fix Harold's brain so he remembers you."

Helen lifted her head. She looked at Jason through tear-flooded eyes. "You... you can heal him? You can heal my Harry?"

"I can certainly try. No promises." Jason said. "But I don't want to see someone's wife cry like this. Especially not old Harold, who's given me so much. If it weren't for him, I would never have obtained my powers. This is the least I can do for the old man."

Helen squeezed Jason's hand. She bobbed her head and stifled a sob as she smiled at the kind young man sitting beside her.

"Oh, Jason... you're such a dear. Even if you can't heal Harry, thank you so much... thank you for being there for him. I'm glad he's had such good friends around him all these years. He has his animals too... I know he hasn't suffered at all. Even if you can't heal him, I'll just have to make him fall in love with me all over again."

Jason's heart skipped a beat. He gave Helen a long, uncomprehending look.

Make her... fall in love... with me again?

Jason's thoughts flickered over to Phoebe. He smiled at Helen, and nodded along to her words.

"Yeah... that... might just work." Jason muttered.

Part 715: Soul Splicing

January 29th, 2021.

Jason felt a bit better after talking to Helen for a while. Something about their similar situations made him feel as if he had someone he could vent to, so they spoke for a while about their shared love of their spouses and how losing their memories hurt their hearts.

But ultimately, Jason didn't plan to leave Helen hanging for long. Her trauma would be short lived compared to his. At the least, he no longer felt completely alone, and the two of them had forged a minor bond. Despite the fact that he was much older than Helen, who was born in the 1910's, Jason almost felt like she had a wonderful motherly or grandmotherly vibe. She was easy to talk to, and he appreciated that. The fact she spoke in the way an old grandmother would from his point of view, due to associations he had made with her lingual dialect as a child, did not hurt the comparison.

As such, he decided to jokingly call her Grandma Helen, which made her blush and feel as if he was teasing her, but the moniker stuck, and she had no choice but to roll her eyes and smile. He did look like a cute older teenage boy, so she wasn't all that resistant.

A few hours later, Jason left Helen and Catherine inside Harold's estate. He brought Nadia along to help him, and then he made a small laboratory dedicated to fixing Harold's problem. With her help, they worked together to craft a special Soul Retention Crystal, and Jason made an artificial duplicate of Harold's soul. This was actually done at Nadia's behest, who suggested operating on a false soul before touching his real one. Jason had never tried something like that in the past, and he found the idea was smarter than immediately jumping into a surgery for the first time on someone still living.

It wasn't as if the Wordsmith had a medical degree. His knowledge of human anatomy, and especially souls, was quite shallow.

"A question comes to mind." Nadia said, pointing at the holographic representation of Harold's soul that was floating in the air above an operation station designed specifically for the coming task. "I've never seen a soul before. Can you confirm for me that other souls all look like this?"

Harold's soul was shaped like a totem that had been carved out of a tree trunk, with many different faces and drawings on its surface depicting animals of all shapes and sizes.

There were cats, dogs, birds, bears, and dozens of other tiny animal faces all wrapping up and around a totemic pole that had a much larger sized version of Harold's face at the top.

Jason shook his head. "All souls are different from one another. It seems Harold has a strong affinity for animals. That's why his appears this way."

"Can you show me what my soul looks like?" Nadia asked.

Jason nodded. He used his Wordsmithing to create a representation of Nadia's soul.

"**Soul. Attach. Projection.**"

As soon as it appeared, he flinched in surprise, and Nadia gasped with a mixture of horror and embarrassment.

Her soul was much more simplistic than Harold's. It was like a white and black orb that spun with energy deep inside its core. On the left side of the orb there was Nadia's face, but on the right side there was Jason's face!

Jason's face?! Why the heck was he a part of Nadia's soul?

Jason gave a long look at Nadia, and as soon as their eyes met, she looked down at the ground, unable to meet his gaze.

"I... I didn't expect... oh, um, I don't know what to say." Nadia said, feeling like a little girl who gotten caught drawing pictures of a boy in her class. "I... I'm sorry, Jason."

Jason's face flushed red with his own sense of embarrassment, followed immediately by a stinging pain in the back of his skull. He immediately realized why his face was represented on Nadia's soul, and that made him feel a sense of guilt at the trauma she had gone through.

"No, don't be." Jason said quietly. "I didn't... realize... your feelings toward me had become so... entrenched."

Entrenched.

It was such a strange word choice. He could have said 'deep' or 'ever-lasting' or something romantic, but he chose a word that put distance between himself and her. He couldn't allow himself to feel anything for her, because his heart was not with her.

Nadia had lived for decades inside her Mind Realm, trapped with a fake version of Jason. She had grown to view that part of him as being her soulmate, and they had bonded so deeply that he had imprinted on her soul. The realization made Jason feel that

working with her could become a problem later on, but also he felt that it would be incredibly traumatizing if he simply pushed her away. He didn't want to hurt her again, especially after what he had accidentally done to her before. He just didn't know how to navigate this social situation.

For a brief moment, Jason wondered what Phoebe's totem would have looked like in the future. Would she had a marker of Jason on her soul?

Would his soul now have Phoebe's face embedded upon it as well?

That question scared him. Jason didn't know, and almost didn't *want* to know, if his love for Phoebe, his obsession with Phoebe, was as deep as Nadia's obsession with him.

"You... owe me nothing." Nadia said quietly. "Please don't let... my soul... influence you. I don't need you to make any moves toward me. Can we simply, um, discuss its appearance in neutral terms?"

She looked up and met Jason's eyes hesitantly. He nodded.

"Yes. Let's do that. Sorry, by the way."

He didn't know why he apologized. Was it because he had seen something so private and intimate that he had thoroughly embarrassed her? Was it because he had imprinted himself on her soul, yet he reciprocated none of her feelings? A mixture of both? Something else? It was anyone's guess.

Still, the two of them were mature adults. They cleared their throats and looked back up at Nadia's soul. She couldn't stop blushing, feeling exposed and naked before him, all of her secrets laid out to dry in the sun. But she soldiered on, ignoring the discomfort.

"Your soul is... extremely energetic." Jason said, choosing not to dwell on the two faces looking back at him. "This is possibly due to your MindCore being so supercharged. Comparatively, Harold's soul is a lot duller. Notice how dim it appears next to yours."

"He's an old man, and a soul who has already died." Nadia observed. "Do you suppose the energy of a soul is related to its youthfulness? Its innate power? Its age? Something else?"

"I'm no soul expert," Jason said, before sneering, "the best one I know is Archangel Raphael, and I'm not about to ask that old fucker any questions on the matter. He could tell me 99% truths and 1% catastrophic lies."

Nadia gave Jason an odd look, realizing just how deep his dislike of Raphael went. She wondered if he'd been completely forthcoming with Catherine on the matter, but decided not to ask.

"We need more data." Nadia said. "We need to look at more souls from many sources."

Jason chewed his lower lip. "Peering into people's souls is... a deep invasion of privacy. You should know that better than anyone."

Nadia grimaced. Having already thoroughly embarrassed herself, she was fully aware of Jason's meaning.

"I... yes. But it's for a good cause. Perhaps we should look at yours?" Nadia said, before her heart skipped a beat. She suddenly realized she wasn't sure what she would see, and she didn't know if she was ready to see it.

Surprisingly, Jason didn't reject the idea. But he did hesitate...

"I... I don't know." Jason said quietly. "I don't mind if you see it. But I don't... I don't want to know what my soul looks like."

This surprised Nadia. Before she could question Jason's reasoning, he lowered his head and rubbed his eyes.

"I already saw your soul. It's only fair you see mine. But I don't want to know what my real self is like. It... the thought... *frightens me*."

Nadia swallowed heavily. She sighed...

"Alright. Show me, but you look away. I'll... collect the data."

Jason kept his fingers pressed against his eyes. "**Soul. Attach. Projection.**"

Jason didn't look up. He refused to examine his inner self. But Nadia saw everything.

"Oh... oh my..." Nadia said quietly.

After a long, long minute, Jason dissipated the projection and looked up. Nadia's face was ashen.

"What?" Jason asked. "What... did you see?"

The blood seemed to have drained from Nadia's face. She smiled, but it was so weak and foced that he knew it couldn't be genuine.

"Your soul is, um... it's a rainbow of colors. But they're all so... dim. It's as if they used to be vibrant, glowing with neon energy, and now they're all..."

She trailed off, allowing Jason to fill in the words himself.

"My soul seems dead, then." Jason said quietly. "That about matches how I feel. No wonder you're so shocked."

"No, that's not it at all." Nadia said. "Harold's soul and mine both had our faces represented. But... but your soul... didn't. Your face wasn't there. Only the faces of-"

"Stop." Jason interrupted, raising his palm. "Don't tell me. Keep it to yourself. Let's just collect more data."

Nadia bobbed her head. Her throat clammed up, and she felt a little stifled by the emotions she was experiencing. Nevertheless, she kept her mouth shut and opted not to speak of what she had seen.

"We'll do... Catherine... next." Jason said, his tone slightly sullen.

With a Word of Power, Jason reached out and scanned Catherine's soul. He created a hologram of hers beside Harold and Nadia's. Immediately, the two of them started making comparisons.

"Catherine's soul is bright like yours." Jason observed. "There are also two faces present. Her face, and... I believe that's Jeanne D'Arc."

"Her soul seems to be constructed almost entirely out of light energy. Holy energy?" Nadia said. "Her soul is extremely fierce. She is brave and even somewhat domineering."

Jason was a little surprised to see his face wasn't present on Catherine's soul. But what was more surprising was that Raphael's face wasn't either. It seemed Catherine's affinity for Raphael didn't dig down nearly as deeply as her love for her long-dead sister. Some bonds could neither be strengthened nor weakened by time.

After moving on from Catherine, Jason sent a Word of Power toward his daughter, elsewhere in Aevum.

"This is Daisy's soul." Jason said, before pausing to stare at it for thirty long seconds. "She... she... her soul..."

Nadia's mood dampened. "It's almost entirely pitch-black. Her face is sad, and there are no other faces present. It's like... there's nothing there?"

"Existential depression." Jason said quietly. "I see a spark of light, right in the core... but there's so much darkness around it. So... so much darkness..."

Nadia lowered her eyes. "I didn't realize Daisy was dealing with such... pain..."

"It's my fault." Jason said, his throat rasping dryly. "I left her alone... all those years."

Jason hesitated. He almost wanted to look at Phoebe's soul, but...

"Let's... stick... to strangers." Jason said haltingly, his words stilted. "No more looking at people we know. It doesn't feel right."

"I agree." Nadia said while rubbing the bridge of her nose. "Just pick some random people on Earth."

What followed next was Jason reaching out with his senses to duplicate the souls of more than fifty men and women across Earth. He chose at random children, adults, old people, even some animals for comparison.

"Everyone's souls are extremely dull." Nadia said at some point in the process. "It's a good thing we checked. Harold's soul has degenerated to the point he's barely any livelier than an ordinary human. But based on these scans, Heroes of any type, be they Lowborn or Trueborn, should have fierce and energetic souls."

"The soul is almost certainly the ultimate conduit for supernatural powers." Jason said. "I'd love to check out the souls of some Low and High Psions, but I'm afraid if I did that, the Volgrim might notice. I suspect High Psion souls are far more energetic than Low Psion souls."

"We can check the demons and angels." Nadia suggested.

And so they did. Jason carefully picked out more than a hundred low ranking angels and demons, followed by a tiny smattering of the highest demons, but he didn't dare to touch the souls of any Archangels.

"Lazarite souls are surprisingly similar in power to pureblooded angels." Jason noted. "The exact compositions vary, but the scale is approximately the same. The difference between Low Demons and High Demons is enormous though."

"I think we have enough data." Nadia said. "I've simulated dozens of ways we can repair Harold's soul. If you follow these steps, adjust these vectors here and here, you should be able to return him to his former glory, except..."

"Except?" Jason asked.

Nadia tapped her chin thoughtfully. She didn't say anything for a few seconds.

"...Harold's Heroic Artifact would block the attempt. We need to extract his soul from it. And if we do that, we can do a little something else."

Jason waited for her to elaborate, but then, all at once, it hit him.

"Wait... are you saying... we could...?"

"Yes." Nadia said seriously. "It's viable. We can make a new body for Harold and put his soul into it. He would not be trapped inside his artifact anymore."

Jason stared at her for a while. He wasn't exactly staring at her, but rather, his MindCore was racing to rebuild several theoretical models he had previously left to rot. Now those old models suddenly made more sense.

"We... we could do this for any Heroic Ancestor." Jason said, his mouth dry. "We could revive any of them. All of them. They would be just as- no, *stronger* than when they were alive, so long as I went to extreme enough lengths when constructing their bodies."

Nadia's face brightened. "That's great news! Right when we need manpower, we can turn all the ancient Heroes into combat viable options! Isn't this exactly what we needed?!"

But despite her enthusiasm, Jason appeared unhappy.

"Let's get one thing straight." Jason said to Nadia solemnly. "Heroes are not good people. Not innately. Some heroes are good. Some are righteous. Some feel larger than life. But Heroes are, ultimately, just human. And putting any ancient Hero inside a powerful body could cause negative effects you don't want to imagine."

Nadia's face dimmed. "You... do you know any bad Heroes?"

"A few." Jason immediately answered. "The worst Hero of all was Dracula. He betrayed humanity to side with the demons. But even though he was the only outright 'evil' Hero, I also had a horrid encounter with a Hero named Samson. He tried to kill my wife, and forced me to kill him to save her life. It was the first time I'd ever executed someone, and it changed me as a person."

Jason closed his eyes. "Then there was Solomon... I don't know if you could call him evil, but he had his own agenda. He manipulated me, he manipulated my clone, and ultimately died a tragic death."

Nadia folded her hands together and twiddled her thumbs. "So what you're saying is, we could create a catastrophe if we revive the wrong Hero. If word gets out among the

Ancient Heroes that we can revive them, they'll all clamor to return to life, and refusing them could turn them into our enemies."

"Solomon alone might have a lot of sway with the other Ancestors." Jason said. "I haven't met him in this timeline. I don't know where his Crown is located. But it seems possible he might have connected with and made friends with some of the other Heroes. King Hammurabi is his teacher, and he was a formidable Ancestor. So if I piss Solomon off, I might turn Hammurabi against me too, and anyone else inclined to follow either of them."

"This... is a problem." Nadia admitted. "But I think you might be overthinking it. If you have the power to revive Heroes, then that gives you a massive amount of bargaining leverage. Unless someone else steals your abilities, the other Heroes will have to fall into line with you if they want to get revived. And the threat of you possibly taking their soul and shoving it back inside their artifacts should keep them in line."

"Should." Jason emphasized. "For now, we'll use Harold as a test case. Let's keep this on the down-low, just you and me, along with Helen, Catherine, and Harold. I'll focus on building him a new Wordsmithium body. It could be nice having an old guy around who can talk to animals. I bet we'll be able to find lots of niche uses for his powers."

"Maybe we can work on making his personality a little brighter too?" Nadia joked. "He does feel a *little* abrasive."

* * *

Jason spent four hours constructing a brand new humanoid body unlike any he had ever made before. He had originally planned on making something based off his Dronesmiths, but those simply didn't feel sufficient. They didn't require sleep, they felt somewhat inhuman to control, and they lacked a lot of features that would make them ideal to live inside.

"My Dronesmiths can consume nutrients for aesthetic reasons but they cannot enjoy the taste of food. They don't need to pee or poop either." Jason said out loud. "They can smell odors without feeling revolted, and can distinguish between those odors with a proficiency that would make a bloodhound blush. But is that really what a revived Hero would want? Or even just a revived human?"

Jason glanced across the display at Nadia, but she didn't answer. Her eyes were closed, and her thoughts were focused inside her Mind Realm, rapidly tweaking and iterating on

improvements to Harold's soul, along with comparing all the data she had gathered from all the other souls they had duplicated. Jason decided not to bug her for an answer and instead thought to himself about solutions.

If I were being revived, I would obviously want a strong, powerful, durable body. But Harold is also married. I imagine once he remembers his wife, he and her might want to... so, uh, I'd better make sure he has lots of 'stamina' and can exert himself well. Should this artificial body be able to produce children? Should a female version be able to give birth? I think that makes sense. Would removing the need for pissing and shitting really be all that bad? Angels don't need to do that. They can just expunge the filthy air from their pores, and it doesn't even smell. Let's just go ahead and clean up a few redundancies...

Jason worked hard. He started making an idealized human form with more thought put into it than ever before. In fact, he even made multiple variants.

Harold is too far gone. He probably won't know what I'm planning to do or be able to care, but Helen will. I'll give her the choice of which body we should put Harold inside, then have her decide.

Jason settled on a few different designs.

One of the bodies was the Basic Human Replicant. The BHR was designed to look and function like any ordinary human, but it had strong regenerative capabilities and no mechanical parts. Anything an ordinary human could do, the BHR could do. Its parameters could be tweaked to allow the user to instantly fall asleep without insomnia, never gain weight even when pigging out, and other sorts of things along that line. It was essentially a normal human body, but optimized along the upper bell curve in every category of what a human could do.

Next, he designed the Superior Human Replicant. The SHR removed a lot of redundant systems. It could experience all the joys of humanity, but no longer needed to 'expunge waste' through its bowels, and was supercharged to be at the level of a Demon Baron in most categories. Anyone possessing a SHR could punch through concrete effortlessly or even toss a car aside if needed. Coupled with insane regenerative capabilities, a SHR-user would likely feel like a superhero from a movie.

The third version he designed was the Inhuman Replicant. The IHR was not like the two before it. It was heavily based on Benjamin Brown's biology from the future, like the

Vanguard he would ultimately become. However, it was more machine than man, and meant to be used as a weapon of war. IHRs had no need for sleep and had built in processing cores that partially mimicked the functionality of a MindCore. The only people Jason thought would be suitable for IHRs were self-sacrificing men and women who wanted bodies powerful enough to fight the enemies of humanity in the coming years, centuries, and millennia.

But what was most amazing was that Jason had actually made it possible for souls to pass through the BHR, SHR, and IHR like a conduit. That is to say, through it wasn't a simple process, a dead person could live inside the body of a BHR to live an authentic human experience, port their body into a SHR to live as a superhuman, or be placed inside an IHR in times of extreme war.

In Jason's mind, this was almost like putting on a set of clothes or a suit of armor depending on the situation.

"They're like sleeves..." Jason muttered to himself. "Slipping into bodies is an insane idea... but jumping between them too often could be a problem. I don't want to expose that souls can jump between bodies for now, since it might cause soul degradation. I'll phrase it as if the decision is permanent."

Jason hadn't woken up that day intending to add another change to humanity's future trajectory, but that was what had happened.

Soon, he and Nadia would move Harold over to a new body, and in the process, they would create a new paradigm for what dead humans could experience...

Part 716: Soul Surgery

January 29th, 2021.

When Jason and Nadia returned, they gave Helen the good news. Her countenance lifted and her heart soared at the realization that not only could Jason heal Harold's dementia, but he could even revive him in a new body. But when Jason told her the options, her expression turned to confusion.

"You're saying you can make him one of three possible bodies?" She asked, as Jason displayed three wireframe holograms in the air.

"That's right." Jason said. "Let's simplify the names for you, granny. Harold can become an Enhanced Human, an Augmented Human, or a War Cyborg. I don't think the last one is appropriate for him, so let's narrow it down to the first two."

Jason discarded the third hologram and left the previous two floating in the air.

"Enhanced Humans are simply... normal humans you'd meet anywhere. They can do all the same stuff as any other human, but they're immortal, have extremely efficient body processes, build muscle easily, don't get fat unless they *seriously* pig out all the time, and they can still, uh, you know... *reproduce*. They still have all the full capabilities of ordinary humans, but at the level of a high performing human in any category you can think of. He'll also be able to heal himself over the course of a week, no matter how serious the injury, outside of a missing limb."

He continued. "Augmented Humans remove some of the human biological needs. They're superhuman in every way. If you think Harold is the type of man who would want to fight in this future war, then this option probably suits him best. His body will become so efficient that he won't need to use the bathroom, and he won't need to eat very often either. He will lose a bit of his humanity, but he'll still be capable of love, passion, and... all the other fun stuff I'm sure you miss about your husband."

Nadia leaned forward to chime in. "This second version can regenerate limbs too, and I've helped Jason quintuple the healing speed. It'll only take a day or two to heal from any injury so long as his head and heart aren't destroyed. Even then, survival is still theoretically possible if the heart is grievously damaged but he receives immediate medical attention."

Helen bit her lip. She looked back and forth between the two images, uncertain of what to choose.

"I... I don't know..." Helen muttered. "This decision involves Harold's future. It doesn't feel right not to include him in the choice."

"You've seen for yourself that Harold isn't in his right mind." Jason said. "Just treat this as if he were in a coma and I were a doctor. You would need to make medical decisions on his behalf, yes? Do you need more help understanding the options, grandma?"

Helen shook her head. "No, I understand the options perfectly well. I have a PhD, you know. I'm simply worried I'll choose the wrong thing and he'll be unhappy with what I picked."

A moment of silence followed. As Helen carefully weighed the options, Catherine stepped forward and laid her arm across Helen's shoulders.

"Why don't we put it to a vote then?" Catherine suggested. "You've told me a lot about Harold over the years. He was a fierce and unstoppable warrior when he fought during the Second World War. I think if his mind was restored, he would feel a great desire to pick up that fight again. I think he would appreciate the power the second body gives him."

Helen glanced at Catherine. "I don't know... Harold, he... he wasn't the same after the war. After what those Nazis *did* to him. They weakened his body, siphoned his power, and damn near stole the soul right out of him. After the war, he would just sit in his chair and watch television for hours a day. I sometimes got him to go out with me, and we went on several vacations, which I loved... but Harold was already starting to slip. I don't know if I want him going back into the fight again. Doesn't he deserve to rest?"

Jason thought about her question for a few moments before carefully forming a reply.

"If Harold was a fierce fighter, someone who loved his country and would do anything to protect it, can I extrapolate that he'd feel even more determined if the entire planet's fate were on the line? Especially a planet filled with the animals he loves?"

Helen nodded. "If you can restore him to what he was like before the war, I don't doubt he'd come roaring back with his former vigor. I fear that my selfish desire to keep him safe and have him all to me would be a waste of his capabilities."

Jason nodded. "If you think he'd rather retire and live an easy life, I won't force him to fight for humanity. Pick the first body. But if you think he'll want to transcend his former limitations and become even more fearsome, pick the second. I leave the decision in your hands."

A long silence fell over the group. Helen's expression hardened as she looked between the two options.

After five long minutes of absolute silence, she slowly nodded.

"Very well. Let's make him an Augmented Human. If I set aside my feelings on the matter, I know this is what Harold would want. He has been trapped inside that television for decades. I believe he would want to stretch his legs and crush demons to pulp with his bare hands. Since that was the man I fell in love with anyway, I have no reason to complain."

"Very well!" Jason exclaimed, smiling broadly at her. "You've made the right decision. I already did most of the prep work, so I'll get right to it. Within two days, your husband will be a new man."

"Thank you, young man." Helen said, smiling sweetly at Jason. "You're a saint."

Jason glanced at Catherine. "Well, actually, if anyone here is a saint, it's her..."

Helen laughed, as did everyone else.

A day and a half later inside Argent City, Jason and Nadia placed Harold's television inside a specially created operation room. It was made with barriers to contain errant souls in the event Jason lost control, so they couldn't get easily sucked up by the Great Beyond. Once they entered, they would be lost forever. Jason wasn't sure if the barrier would work, but it was the best he could come up with.

"You know," Nadia said, looking at Jason across the rounded operating table where Harold's soul would soon be placed, "it occurs to me that what we're doing is Soul Manipulation. Didn't you call the Archangels evil for doing that?"

Jason shook his head. "I've come to believe that 'soul manipulation' is a term of ignorance. Demons perform 'soul manipulation', but how do they do it? By crudely devouring souls and jamming them into their bodies before forcibly merging them with their own souls to uplift themselves. This turns their souls into a sloppy soup of mushy

paste, reducing their qualitative power while increasing their quantitative power. The angels long ago did exactly the same thing, devouring each other to make themselves stronger. But ultimately, how is that really 'soul manipulation'? It's like calling someone a chef because they tossed a bunch of random ingredients into a bowl and mixed them together with no thought."

"That's a good point." Nadia said, tapping her lips. "Then... what do you suppose we should call the two?"

"Something with more nuance." Jason snarked. "Let's call the angel and demon way 'Soul Slop'. What we're doing is 'Soul Surgery'. Right? That's exactly what this is. We're making careful, targeted changes to one man's soul. We're not shoving other souls in there, we're just performing an operation to fix Harold up. I think the real thing the Highest On High wants to avoid is precisely what the angels and demons did. What we're doing is clearly within the spirit of the Akashic Rules."

"Soul Surgery." Nadia repeated. "Maybe we should create an entire discipline for humanity called Soul Science? We could research healthy ways to manipulate souls without breaking taboos, hurting people, or committing acts of evil."

"Sure. Put that idea on the ol' list." Jason said with a smile. "But shelve it for now. Let's focus on Harold first."

And so they did. Jason levitated Harold's TV to a spot beside the operating table. Then he summoned a powerful body made exactly in Harold's image, but much younger. Harold's body, that of an Augmented Human, was changed to resemble his younger self, around the ages of 35 to 40. He had thick blonde hair and blue eyes and a muscular physique that was much less impressive-looking than a peak human bodybuilder, but which secretly contained far more power.

Then, without any fanfare, Jason used several Words of Power to carefully extract Harold's soul from his artifact and contain it in a bubble of energy. Nadia wore a pair of goggles that allowed her to see the soul, goggles that were made by Jason, naturally. She was not going to directly affect Harold's soul during the surgery, but instead use her eyes to spot flaws Jason might have overlooked as the surgery progressed.

"Alright, start the timer." Jason said. "Prepping quadrants A1 to A3 now. **Examine. Separate. Peel.**"

Carefully, Jason began surgically pulling apart specific parts of Harold's complex totemic soul. Over the course of the next several hours, he carefully inserted large quantities of Heroic Energy taken from himself and from Aevum's Spire to inflate Harold's weak soul. With those pathways reconstructed, Jason reached into Harold's shattered memories and started rebuilding them. Unlike a living human with dementia or Alzheimer's, Harold's soul had simply garbled his lost memories instead of destroying them. Jason was able to resequence the memories by also occasionally dipping into Helen's memories, which she had graciously offered to assist in the surgery.

Three hours passed, and Jason successfully repaired Harold's soul.

Another two hours passed, and Harold's memories had been rebuilt. Already, his soul was awakening and becoming fiercely energetic. Jason frowned as he realized containing such a powerful soul struggling to break free of its shackles was more difficult than he expected.

Suddenly, Nadia pointed at something Jason had overlooked. "There! What is that bright green spot?"

Jason quickly examined it with a Word of Power. His jaw dropped. "That's Harold's Heroic Aura! It's still there! A fragment of it, at least. Those fucking Nazis failed to steal all of it! Hahaha, this is great! That means I can take an extra step I thought I wouldn't be able to."

Jason steeled his heart, then heaved a deep breath.

"**Rejuvenate.**"

Carefully, Jason poured energy inside of Harold's nearly dead Heroic Aura, reviving it and empowering it back to its original level. This ensured that his Heroic Powers would fully manifest, since Jason wasn't sure if they would have done so originally. Losing the ability to speak to animals would surely be a huge blow to Harold's heart, and now Jason had ensured that would no longer be the case.

But as the energy stabilized, Harold's soul became increasingly more powerful. It had even surpassed Jason's strength, and Jason was only able to contain it because he had the advantage of a living body.

"Aargh! Come on, Harold! Calm down! This is for your own good, you stubborn bastard!" Jason hissed through his teeth. "Stop squirming like a kid at the dentist! Damn!

DAMN! Okay fine, the surgery is done! It's DONE already, let me just put you in your new body! Gah, you slippery old fuck! Quit trying to break free!!"

Harold's soul bounced around inside the bubble of containment energy Jason had made. He started to move it toward Harold's body, but all of a sudden, the soul exploded with power and shattered the containment bubble, then dove toward the body hanging before it with ravenous desire.

FWOOOOM!!

A blinding light erupted as the body and soul seamlessly combined, forcing Jason and Nadia to take a step back. Jason gaped at the body, his mouth hanging open. "They merged?? I didn't even have to use my Wordsmithing? How is that even possible?!"

Several seconds of silence passed. Then, Harold's eyes slowly fluttered open.

"Nice work, kiddo." Harold grunted, though his speech was a little slurred. "Y'did it. Ya brought me back to life."

"You know what's happened?" Jason asked. "You knew about the surgery?"

"Hurt like the dickens!" Harold said, his hands twitching as he tried to move. "Cuttin' into me, carvin' me like a pumpkin. But I knew it was for a good cause. Just wish you'd knocked me out so I didn't feel the pain! Do you gots any idea just how much it hurts to have yer damn SOUL sliced??"

"I thought I did knock you out..." Jason muttered, aggrieved.

Harold's body twitched a bit more energetically, but it was clear he had not yet mastered moving around.

"You're going to need time to acclimate to controlling your body." Jason said. "I didn't even get to fuse your soul with your body! How did you control your soul and take over the body so fluidly?"

"Sorry, kid." Harold said, his mouth working more smoothly than before. "I knew ya had more ya wanted to do, but I was antsy to git back in m'body. I gots a dame waiting for me, after all."

Jason raised his eyebrows and nodded. "Helen is going to be very happy to see you. I'll bring her in right away."

"WAIT! No, no way, punk." Harold immediately objected. "I ain't gonna hang here like a cripple. You just gimme a bit. I gots this."

Harold struggled. His expression darkened as he focused on moving his fingers and toes. Then, his legs started to move. He twitched his entire body, still hanging from the mount Jason had made, with straps wrapped under his armpits and around his chest.

Minutes passed. Soon, an entire hour had come and gone. Jason and Nadia watched in fascination as Harold improved his control of his new body faster and faster every minute. He eventually stood up, removed the restraints, and staggered slightly as he struggled to control the full weight of his new body.

"Hot diggity dog!" Harold crowed. "Now this is a damn fine body y'made me, son! I'm a little shaky now, but I bet once I'm fully *accliminaturalized* I'll be shootin' hoops with the young 'uns!"

"You'll be doing a lot more than that." Jason said. "I gave your wife the choice of three bodies we could put you in. She chose the second one."

Jason quickly explained the three options to Harold, and the old man continued to move around, standing firmer and taller as he practiced walking back and forth. Despite his focus, Harold had a keen mind, and he listened intently to Jason's words.

"Interesting. I wouldn't'a minded the third option, but this here augment-body is quite nice! I believe you done-did outdone yourself, if I don't say so, boy!"

Finally, Harold puffed out his chest. His eyes flared with energy as he grinned and looked around the room. "Son, you gots a place 'round here where I can put this body through the ringer? Just a lil' bit 'fore I go out there and give my lady a hug'n'kiss. I feel strong now, maybe a lil' *too* strong. Wouldn't wanna hurt her or nothin' like that."

"Sure thing, Harold." Jason said. "**Teleport.**"

With a Word of Power, Jason swept himself, Nadia, and Harold away, bringing them to a training area on the opposite side of Argent, far from where Helen and Catherine were.

"I told Helen the surgery might take around half a day, and it's been about eight hours. Still, you shouldn't keep a lady waiting." Jason said.

"This won't take long." Harold said, strutting over to a set of steel squares with handles on their sides.

Each cube was exactly the same size, but they had been designed by Jason to have different weights. They were all a little smaller than a mini-fridge, and the first one said *one ton* while the second said *two tons* and so on, stacking all the way up to ten tons.

"That body is rated at the level of an average Demon Baron." Jason explained. "You should be able to lift ten tons with a bit of eff-"

Jason's words caught in his throat when Harold walked over, grabbed the ten-ton cube, and casually lifted it off the ground with one hand. He didn't even appear to be straining himself.

"Son, you gots anything heavier than this here toothpick?" Harold inquired.

Jason's mouth went dry. "What the... that's not right. I definitely didn't make the body that strong... let me check something. **Manifest. Enhance.**"

Jason conjured another cube behind Harold. This one was noticeably larger, and it had a weight of twenty tons listed on the front.

Harold found wrapping his arms around it to be impossible due to its size, but he still grabbed the nearest handle and effortlessly lifted one end off the ground. After shimmying his body underneath the cube, Harold let out a little 'hup!' and lifted it onto his back, then chucked it a few feet away, causing a violent *boom* when it struck the ground.

"That it?" Harold asked. "I said heavier, son! HEAVIER! You got a bucket o' bolts bangin' around in that there head of yours?"

Jason began to frown. This time, he created a new set of weights, two huge rounded spheres with a bar made of Wordsmithium between them. These cubes were incredibly dense and weighed fifty tons each!

"There we go. That's a lil' bit more sensible." Harold said, nodding in approval.

The old man walked over, grasped the bar, then heaved with considerably more effort than before.

"Hrrgh! Yeah! YEAH! Now that's a damn workout!"

Jason's jaw dropped. Even though Harold was straining himself, it seemed 100 tons wasn't even close to his limit.

"Based on the strain his body is under, Harold seems capable of lifting more than 250 tons." Nadia observed. "This is far, far beyond what we anticipated. His physical body has the power of a Demon Emperor, not a Demon Baron. And a strong one at that."

"The body is no different from the specs I designed." Jason said, picking his jaw off the ground. "It's Harold himself who has enhanced the body. Wait..."

Jason slapped his face. "How did I forget? Harold had super strength and other powers during the war. Now that I've fixed his Heroic Aura, those powers are supercharging his new body!"

Jason remembered that Sebastian had told him about Harold's powers in the past, but Jason hadn't taken them too seriously until now. He had assumed that if Harold obtained a powerful new body, he would only be as strong as he was during the war. It turned out the two factors stacked together exponentially, making him vastly more powerful than before he died.

"Well. This is certainly a good omen." Nadia said with a smile. "We've revived a powerhouse who will put the fear of the Creator back in the demons."

"Damn right, he will." Jason said, smiling back.

* * *

After an hour of exercising, Harold had finally taken measure of his strength. Jason teleported them to Harold's estate, and on arrival, all the animals perked up.

"It's... it's him! The Archseer succeeded! Father is alive!!"

A stampede of critters came rushing over, their voices a roaring cacophony of happiness and excitement. Harold's fierce masculine aura faded a little as he broke down in tears hugging many of them.

"Ohh, Sebastian, Robby, Theodor... I can finally hold and pet you all again... oh, gosh-golly, this is the best day of m'ding-damn life... sniff..."

From the distance, a voice called out.

"Harold?"

Harold stiffened. He lifted his head, then smiled broadly at the beautiful angel with fair white hair gazing at him with teary eyes.

"Helen..." Harold sniffled. "Mah dame!"

He stood up and rushed toward her, and she rushed toward him. The two of them fell into each other's arms and embraced vigorously, with Helen bursting into tears as she began to sob uncontrollably.

"Oh, Harold..."

"Helen! Helen!!"

Jason's eyes welled up with tears. He felt happy for them. He envied them. He wanted what they had for himself. He closed his eyes and wiped away his tears, sobbing wholeheartedly as man and wife embraced just a stone's throw away.

It was worth it. All his effort had been worth it.

Part 717: New Confidantes

January 29th, 2021. Argent City, Aevum.

An hour passed. Jason and the others all sat down inside Harold's manor, with the old man now looking a lot younger and more refreshed. Helen, after becoming a Lazarite, had returned to the prime of her life, and the same was true of Harold. Both of them now looked like a middle-aged couple somewhere in their 30's to 40's, and they were both all smiles as they looked at one another adoringly. It was almost sickening how precious they acted, having regained each other after all these years. They were like lovesick teenagers, desperate to hug and kiss one another, but momentarily stymied by social pressures to act primly and properly in front of their guests.

The entire group discussed many things. Most importantly, with his mind restored, Harold became incredibly sharp. It didn't take long before Jason realized he wasn't some dumb country bumpkin, but something of a strategic leader with a sizable intellect. Harold's funny way of speaking contrasted with his many years of military service. It turned out that during the war, he hadn't been any ordinary soldier, but a platoon leader who had many victories under his belt.

"So this here war that's comin', it's a big one, eh?" Harold mused, massaging his short but handsome blonde beard. "Not just the planet, but the galaxy. That's some crazy stuff yer' talkin' about there, son."

Jason nodded. "I've given us a lot of time to prepare. If things go well, we can keep the situation in Aevum secret long enough for me to develop multiple methods for empowering humanity."

He used his Wordsmithing to create a series of floating images in the air, depicting not only Aevum itself above everyone's heads, but images of projects he had been working on.

"First things first, this is where we are right now." Jason said, directing his attention to Harold and Helen equally. "This is Aevum. It is an artificial planet hidden in the Milky Way Galaxy, far, far, far away from Earth. It is completely isolated and totally secret. Using my magic, I can transfer people and items to Earth and back with relative ease. Even if our enemies knew Aevum existed and wanted to attack it, just finding it would be damn near impossible."

Harold nodded. "Location... logistics... lots'a thought put into this shebang."

"Aevum flows at an accelerated time speed." Jason explained. "Simply put, one day on Earth is one year in here. That means for every month we delay the Volgrim or demons from learning about Aevum, we'll gain 30 years of preparation time."

The old man's eyes lit up. "You don't say? So we can prepare all sorts o' stuff in secret, train an army, equip 'n outfit them, and nobody'd be the wiser?"

"Not one soul." Jason said.

The Wordsmith paused, then grinned wryly as he looked at the faces present. "The only problem is, this place is not going to stay secret forever. A decent number of people not only know about me, but have at least some idea of Aevum's existence. We should operate under the assumption that a spy, a traitor, or even a casual slip-up could lose us our information advantage."

Seeing Harold simply nodding along while thinking about things to himself, Jason continued speaking.

"Here's a small handful of the programs I've been working on..."

"First, the new body I just gave Harold. I believe it could be possible to revive humans who have died inside of these exceptionally powerful bodies. Specifically, Heroic Ancestors like Harold. But I want you to keep this on the down-low for now. There's no need to rush this process, and I'm worried about the less than pure motivations of certain Heroes from the past."

"Next is a project I originally brought Helen here to talk about: Mindcores. I can access certain humans' souls to open up a large space inside their 'Mind Realm', then I can install one of five extremely powerful secondary artificial brains. These brains are made with spiritual energy combined with computer-like programming systems. They can enhance a person's creativity, allow them to learn quickly, grant access to simulated realities, enhance their reflexes and combat knowledge, or even help them predict the future in limited ways."

Helen looked at Jason with surprise. "Are you saying you wish to give me one of these... Mindcores?"

"Yes." Jason said. "I already talked to Catherine about it, but let's hold off on that for a short while. I'll get back to it after this."

Helen bobbed her head obediently, allowing Jason to continue.

"So far, we have a way to revive powerful elite Heroes from the dead, and to augment the brains of humans so they're a lot smarter. The next thing to think about is enhancing normal humans to become a lot more effective. To that end, I've started developing highly advanced armor systems based on technological and magical principles that will allow ordinary humans to become much more effective soldiers. I have these older designs known as T-REX's, which are nanite-based armor solutions, but I'm developing new ones, such as SIGIL, which is less like armor and more like forced temporary empowerment of a person's body."

He continued. "On top of all that, did you guys see those cubes that were levitating in the sky? Those are Simulacrums, where augmented and ordinary humans can enter to train their skills in a safe virtual environment."

Harold lifted his head to look out the window. He easily spotted one of the cubes Jason had mentioned; a giant obsidian chunk of metal with faint grey geometric energy patterns inscribed on its surface.

"...Yer gonna just throw people in those and train 'em that way?" Harold asked.

"That was the plan." Jason said, before pausing awkwardly. "I haven't made a lot of them yet, but I was going to make more. I mean... unless you have a better idea?"

The centennial man scratched his head and gave Jason a weird look. "Son, you ain't a military man, are ya? You never enlisted?"

Jason slowly shook his head. "Not exactly. I formed a military in the future I came from. But we lost a lot of fights. I wasn't formally trained in a drill camp or whatever."

"Yeah... that's 'bout what I expected." Harold said quietly. "Look son, I ain't knockin' your work. This is a real good skeleton of a plan you've got goin' on here. But that's all it is. Just a skeleton. You're hopin' to out-tech yer way to a big fat victory. That about right?"

Jason cocked his head. "I don't follow?"

Harold threw up his hands and laughed. "Bahaha! Then lemme spell it out for ya! This plan is doomed to fail unless ya carefully bake some crucial ingredients into the mix!"

Harold leaned forward, clasped his hands together, and rested his elbows on his knees.

"The Vietnam War. You know anything about it?"

"Sure." Jason said, before pausing to add, "Though it did happen like two decades before I was born."

"Lot more'n two decades." Harold said with a laugh, as if he'd just heard a naive kid say something pitifully dumb. "Look, I don't remember exactly when I bit the ice, but I know it was around '75. I watched that shithole of a war play out and it gave me a real belly full of laughs. Can you imagine a technologically superior country like the US-of-A not absolutely stomping all over a bunch of poorly equipped farmers-turned-militia?"

Harold threw his head back and roared with laughter. "But we didn't win! We done got our asses handed to us! And if you keep going the way yer' goin', we're gonna be the USA while our enemies are the Viet Cong! We'll have all the tech, all the resources, and still lose every engagement!"

Jason's face darkened with worry. "You're saying I'm putting too much faith in my technological solutions to win a war?"

"Way too much." Harold said, leaning back in his chair. "We lost 'cause them slippery treehuggers played to their strengths. They used the terrain to their advantage. They used guerilla warfare and ambushes. They laid traps. They made our boys in green look like fools. And sure, the good ol' USA won lots of battles, but we sure as shit didn't win the war! It was a DAMN embarrassment!"

Harold paused for a moment to take a breath. He closed his eyes and fell into thought.

"Look, you know what wins wars? Supply lines, logistics, and training. You can have ten times the soldiers 'n ten times the firepower, but if your boys are runnin' around like headless chickens, they'll die when the gunfire starts. That's why these here training cube thingies ain't good enough."

Jason raised an eyebrow. "The false realities they produce are extremely realistic."

"I don't doubt that." Harold calmly replied. "But see, to train a man right 'n proper, ya gots ta' blood him. Training soldiers ain't about showing 'em a bunch of proper ways to react to field situations. It's about drillin' into them that when their CO says 'jump' they ask 'How high, Sarge'! These cubes could be good, but we've gotta git a human element in there. Lucky for you, I've got a decade of trainin' fresh maggots under mah belt. You leave that part to me."

Jason wanted to retort, but frankly, Harold's offer came at a perfect time. He had been debating putting Neil Adams in charge again, but a fellow Hero was probably a better idea.

"We'll talk about this later, but I think it's a good idea." Jason said. "I'll let you think up some ideas for training, and see if I can help you recruit some high level commanding soldiers from Earth to be your underlings. In the meantime, let's move on."

Jason waved his hand. A section of Aevum was highlighted in the east side of Argent City.

"Over here we have one of many sectors I'm devoting to researching more methods to empower humanity. You have to understand that in my eyes, the demons are not humanity's primary threat. The Volgrim are. If we put all our eggs into the basket of defeating the demons, we'll die shortly afterward to the Volgrim. That's because the Volgrim have a galaxy-sized army of warriors where many of the weaker ones can casually destroy planets! The strongest demon currently in existence is a mere ant before the power of a 7th-Level Psion, let alone an 8th or 9th Level Psion."

"This is the Enlightenment Tree, or maybe we can call it the Tree of Possibilities." Jason said, zooming in on an underground area filled with artificial sunlight in the east sector. "I had to place it underground due to limited room on the surface, but it also serves to isolate the room and allow the tree to grow in peace. Of course, it also protects it from thieves and evildoers, since it's growing inside a reinforced bunker."

"What's this Enlightenment Tree all about?" Helen asked. Catherine seemed interested too.

Jason paused. He glanced at Catherine. For a brief moment, he wondered if the things he was saying now would make their way back to Raphael's ears. But over time, he had noticed Catherine was trusting him more and more, and on top of that, he'd inadvertently seen that her soul contained no direct affinity to Raphael.

He decided to trust in Catherine. If she did tell Raphael, it would put a major roadblock in front of Jason's plans, but it wouldn't be the end of the world. Jason would merely have to adapt.

"...The Tree of Possibilities is a very special item. It hasn't yet done anything useful because it is immature, but I designed it to collect small amounts of spiritual energy from all across Aevum, Earth, and Heaven, and slowly use that energy to mutate

'enlightenment fruits'. These fruits, when consumed, can grant all sorts of powerful abilities and boons to people. At least, it should in theory. I have no control over what fruits the tree develops, and I don't want control either. I can already create focused powers for people, such as by giving them a MindCore. What I want is for the tree to grant extremely unique abilities my magic cannot create, and for it to surprise me with niche utility functions."

Harold raised his eyebrows and nodded. He seemed impressed.

"Sounds like the tree from the Garden of Eden." Helen said. "Do you think the fruit it grows could poison or hurt people?"

"Possibly. We won't know until it finally bears fruit." Jason said.

Jason pointed to several other areas around Aevum.

"Many of these spots are empty right now, but I plan to create all sorts of highly advanced factories, automated industrial plants, experimentation bays, scientific research facilities, and so on. The Bio-Loom, the Aegis Womb, Reality Printer, Nursery, Swallower, Threshold, Soulforge..."

Jason trailed off, then shrugged.

"When I build them, I'll tell you guys. Let's not get bogged down in details for now. The important point is that I plan to make Aevum the capital of humanity's future Galactic Empire. Obviously, if the Volgrim or some other adversary wipes us out, then all of this will be for naught, so we have to make sure we ultimately prevail. Once Aevum's core facilities are completed, we can focus on expansion and adding living space for billions of humans."

Catherine tilted her chin up. "I think you are making a mistake."

Jason blinked. He hadn't expected such blunt criticism from Heaven's Daughter.

"What do you mean by that?" Jason carefully asked.

"Aevum is a wonderland." Catherine said, taking the time to explain herself. "It is vital to humanity's operations. It should not be a place for common rabble to live. Only humanity's elites who have contributed or who can contribute to the war effort should be offered such a privilege. If you have created Aevum, can I assume you are capable or making other bubble-worlds?"

Jason nodded. "Of course."

"Then do so. Finish your work with Aevum, then make detached bubble worlds; fortresses where humans can live with less fear of dying to the Volgrim or whoever. The more people you put inside Aevum, the higher the likelihood of introducing saboteurs, spies, bad actors, and other seedy villains who would undermine its functions."

After Catherine finished, she expected Jason to follow up on her idea and maybe ask some questions. Instead, he simply smiled.

"Well... actually, Catherine... I didn't mention this part yet, but... that was always my plan."

"What? It was?" Catherine asked.

"Yes. I said I would add expansion and living space for billions of humans, but I didn't exactly mean inside Aevum itself."

Jason scratched his chin. He suddenly felt unsure of how he should phrase this next part. If Catherine leaked this information, it would absolutely fuck him over badly. Trusting her now meant inviting her into his inner circle in a way he wasn't entirely sure he should...

...But he ultimately relented. Maybe it was because Catherine had given him no reason to distrust her, or maybe because she was so beautiful and had an innocent face, or maybe it was even just because he felt guilty about the way he'd overloaded her psyche during the MindCore operation, but either way, he decided if he was going to trust her, he needed to go all the way.

Jason swallowed his saliva heavily, making a barely audible *gulp* sound. Everyone seemed to notice it.

"I am... in possession of... a primordial artifact." Jason said slowly, hesitantly. "I did not make this artifact. Archangel Camael did, a long time ago... before Raphael's mindwipes."

"What?!" Catherine exclaimed, showing visible shock for the first time in a while. "What sort of artifact? What is it??"

Jason quietly sighed. There was no going back now. He conjured an image in the air.

"This is Camael's Cube. It might have a proper name, but if it does, I don't know what it is. Camael once used the Cube to contain the body of the dark dragon, Leviathan, but he broke out and escaped to Earth. Now he hides here, somewhere, in absolute secrecy. I do

not believe he is an evil dragon, but... that's beside the point. His existence is not too important compared to the existence of this Cube."

The blood drained from Catherine's face as she mulled over the gravity of what Jason was telling her. Like him, she now realized that he was holding nothing back. He was trusting her with information that could ruin his plans if she were to tell Raphael or Camael.

That sense of shock slowly turned to a feeling of warmth. Catherine wanted to draw closer to Jason, but there had always been a wall between them. He had concealed information from her, and she knew he had, but she hadn't wanted to press him on the matter. The fact he was revealing such vital intelligence to her now meant he was taking a leap of faith and praying she wouldn't betray him.

"Thank you for... for telling me this." Catherine said, her cheeks flushing slightly red from happiness and a slight bit of embarrassment at her swelling feelings for the man. "I know what it means that you did, and... I won't betray your confidence in me."

Jason let out a breath he didn't know he was holding. He hadn't even said anything to Catherine directly, but she had naturally picked up on what speaking of the Cube meant. As such, it felt as if a weight had lifted from his shoulders.

"I appreciate that." Jason said, smiling back at her. He schooled his expression before continuing. "Camael's Cube is bigger than you can possibly imagine. The entirety of the Sol star system, including its Oort Cloud, could fit inside this cube tens of times over. I plan to build a micro-galaxy inside the Cube, with multiple stars carefully placed to create the widest possible habitation zones. We will be able to place tens, hundreds, even thousands of worlds the size of Earth inside. And frankly, we can do even better than that. Because of my magic, we don't have to rely on the inefficient design of a planet either."

Nadia spoke for the first time. "I've already designed the preliminary sketch for a Folded World. Planets are inefficient because the living space they provide is limited to the planet's surface, building up into the sky, and perhaps a kilometer or two down into the crust. The entire core of a planet is essentially a massive waste of living space. By creating Folded Worlds, people will be able to live comfortably above the surface, on the surface, or underground without any problems. We will create a comfortable level of gravity on these Folded Worlds through artificial means, freeing up the core of the planet to become a massive living space."

"To put that in perspective," Jason explained, "imagine that if humanity efficiently lived in skyscrapers across Earth right now, with the optimal amount of space designated for wildlife, forests, growing zones for food and so on, we could probably fit a trillion people on the planet with ease. But on a Folded World, we could fit 100 trillion people, because the amount of space that would open up below the surface would be multiple orders of magnitude greater!"

"And that's not all!" Nadia excitedly chimed in. "Because the Volgrim capital world is one massive super-city. It doesn't even have wildlife or green-zones. If we took things to their logical extreme with a folded world... well, to be honest, it would be a really boring and sterile place to live, but in terms of raw population, we would not need to worry about living space for humanity."

Helen and Harold glanced at one another. They seemed to speak to each other with their eyes.

"It seems you done gots everything all planned out." Harold said, returning his gaze to Jason. "I gots no problem with any o' that. Right now, we just need to git to work and build all this stuff."

"Time seems like our biggest constraint." Helen observed. "Even if this magical realm is time-accelerated, we still have so much work to do that every second counts. Until we've beaten the Volgrim, we cannot rest on our laurels."

Jason started to say something about the Threat beyond the galaxy's confines, but after a moment of thought, he stopped himself.

He came back in time from 100,000 years in the future. The Threat had not pierced the galactic wall even by that point, and 100,000 years seemed like plenty of time to leave well enough alone for now. Humanity might have beaten the Volgrim by then, and at that point they could worry about the Dark Ones. As for the Kolvaxians, those were still a few thousand years away, and Jason intended to fortify the Cosmic Realm so that the Dark Ones couldn't slip their Kolvaxian soldiers inside through whatever twisted means they had originally used.

Sadly, Jason did not know the truth about the Kolvaxians, or his gaze would have landed squarely on a few specific individuals already living on Earth...

"So! Helen!" Jason said, clapping his hands loudly. "That brings me back around to you."

"To me?" Helen repeated.

Jason smiled.

"We've got a lot of work to do. Harold's alive again, and now... it seems the time has come for me to give your mind a major upgrade."

He waved his hand, causing five mystical objects to appear as holograms above the table.

"So, let's talk about giving you a MindCore." Jason said with a smile.

Part 718: Titan Tensions

January 29th, 2021. Base of Mount Sinai, 4PM.

It had taken the demon six hours following their rapid assault on Saint Catherine's Monastery. They had wiped out the defenders, but hadn't bothered chasing any stragglers. A few humans escaping meant nothing to them when their true goal was so close at hand.

Emperor Satan arrived around 2PM and spent a couple hours organizing the preliminary forces for their intended strike into the heart of Sinai. In order to fortify their position, the demons had surrounded the mountain with multiple structures built by Burrowers and reinforced with high level magic. As it just so happened, they had several Fairy allies who were capable of setting up formations to reinforce these otherwise unremarkable stone structures.

Tens of the mini citadels surrounded Mount Sinai, and each one had a Warper or two inside, holding open portals elsewhere on Earth, usually in the vicinity of one of the major Hells. In this way, reinforcements could arrive within moments, and more and more demons were already making their way to the battlefield.

Angels flew high in the sky. Demons didn't usually have wings, and only a few had the gift of flight, so the angels had a huge defensive advantage by controlling the skies. Unfortunately, the angels lacked in champions capable of fighting at the levels of Dukes and Emperors. Purebloods were few and far between, and most Lazarites could only measure up to Barons at best. It was the few living Archangels who were capable of outfighting the demons, and they were badly outnumbered.

In total, only four Archangels still walked the world of the living. They were Raphael, Camael, Gabriel, and Uzziel. Gabriel wore Michael's ring, but aside from these four, there were no others still among the living. Brother Samael had fallen long ago, prior to the War in Heaven, and Sister Uriel had her soul stolen by the demons. As for the two long-dead ancient archangels, Muriel and Cassiel, they were not worth speaking about. They were so distant in memory that none of the demons knew of them, save for Satan, who secretly concealed Samael's soul within himself...

Thus, with only four champions at their disposal, the angels seemed not to be in a good position. However, the demon leaders knew the situation would be far from a cakewalk.

At the base of the mountain, four demon leaders gathered together to discuss the coming battle. Among them were Satan, Diablo, Lucifer, and Auger.

"We're not able to open any portals inside Heaven." Diablo said, as he walked over and clapped his hand on Satan's shoulder. "We've been trying for hours, but Heaven's dimension has been fortified and rearranged. We can't get a mental lock on any of the ancient monuments."

"Cheh. I never thought we would. It was worth a try, though." Satan said, as he rubbed his chin and looked up at the mountain. "Looks like the only way inside is through Heaven's Gate."

Diablo scratched his head. "I do not understand. Why don't the angels simply close the gate and retreat inside?"

"Hehehe. Our enemies ain't just worried about saving their hides." Satan said knowingly. "Think of the message this would send to the human leaders observing the situation. Standing firm and defending against our attacks signals their bravery and willingness to stand up to us. But cowering inside the mountain and closing themselves off would indicate weakness. What do you think would happen to the Vatican's prestige if the angels acted like a bunch of scared lil' babies?"

"Their entire religious infrastructure would collapse." Auger said, throwing his hat into the discussion. "The angels need humans to pray to them, and the human governments only tacitly support the angels because they fear their wrath. But if the angels bunker up inside of Heaven, they will simply hand us an easy win."

Lucifer filed her long razor sharp nails. "Even if the angels disable Heaven's Gate, they can still open portals outside of Heaven. You place too much faith in them trying to maintain an appearance of bravery."

"It ain't just about appearances, sweet-cheeks." Satan laughed cruelly. "Hahaha, Mount Sinai is symbolic! If they turn off the gate, we'll take over the mountain and never let them reopen it! They'll suffer a humiliation 10,000 lifetimes couldn't wash away! Doesn't matter if they make a new Heaven's Gate elsewhere on Earth, because once we

roll up on that one, they'll have to disable it too, and the next one, and the next one. Everyone'll know the Archangels are just a bunch of paper tigers!"

"So they must fight." Diablo said, nodding slowly. "Good. We need them to fight if we hope to achieve our strategic objectives. Speaking of which..."

Diablo turned a slow, withering gaze toward the Devil.

"...isn't it about time you told us what this is *really* all about?"

Auger and Lucifer both glanced at Diablo in surprise. He wasn't usually the type to care about this sort of stuff. But since he had asked, and since they were both dying to know, they immediately fixated their gazes on Satan, crossed their arms, and waited for his reply.

"Haha! Alright, I'll tell ya!" Satan said. "Now's a good time to spill the beans anyway, Deebs!"

He leaned in and lowered his voice.

"We're gonna take down the Lazarus Tower. Without it, everything the angels hold dear will collapse."

The other Emperors looked at Satan in surprise.

"That is a bold move." Lucifer said approvingly, before her face turned ugly. "But there's no chance of success! I hear the Lazarus Tower is positioned right in the heart of Hrothgar's Hall! There are multiple Titans living right next to it. Any assault force will get crushed into meat paste, even if we send Bael himself!"

"If our goal was to destroy the Lazarus Tower, it would indeed be pretty much impossible." Satan conceded. "But good thing that's not the plan. I intend to steal back Valac's Lantern and retake the power of the Lazarites for ourselves!"

Auger's eyes widened. "You want to steal the lantern? That is even more impossible. Satan, are you really risking all our lives over such a risky gamble?!"

"Again, your lives ain't at risk, unless you rush in like a bunch'a morons." Satan said, waving his hand flippantly. "That's why we got mooks to do the dirty work. Even if we lose ten million Grunts during this assault, so what? Sing 'em a eulogy and move on. We're just gonna hafta' make sure none of our big guys get knocked off by the Archangels, the Titans, or..."

"The Heroes." Auger said, his face contorting into a grimace.

Lucifer's ears perked up. She smiled like a witch, then put on an innocent expression.

"Did you say *Heroes*? Oh that reminds me, my dear sweet precious little Ose just brought me back some intriguing news. It must have slipped my mind!"

"News?" Satan asked. "What news?"

Lucifer moaned as she slowly cracked her back and stretched her legs, taking an annoyingly long time to reply while she forced the others to hang on her every word.

"Oh dear, it seems... you boys didn't hear? If only you had a brilliant, smart, beautiful daughter like me, you might already know. Ah, but where are my manners? I suppose I can tell you."

Her smile disappeared.

"The Hero named Cat Mask is more frightening than we may know. He has the ability to rewind time. It seems he has done so countless times, and he may even know our entire plan going forward, as well as how to counter us."

"WHAT?!" Satan roared, staggering backward in alarm. "Why didn't you tell us sooner?! This is awful news!!"

Lucifer shrugged. "I only learned a couple of hours ago. It seems Ose had a run-in with Cat Mask, and he defeated her handily. Thanks to her cunning wit, she managed to extract several important secrets from his lips before she beat a cunning escape. That's how we now know this entire plan could be a trap! The angels may have already been forewarned of Satan's plan by Cat Mask!"

A moment of silence followed. Auger frowned.

"Something isn't adding up. If Cat Mask can rewind time, then how could Ose possibly have escaped on her own? Especially if he could easily defeat her. If I were him, I would have killed her to prevent my secret from spreading."

"No, that's not right." Diablo interjected. "Because if you could rewind time, then even if your secret got out, you'd just rewind later and undo it."

"GENTLEMEN!" Satan shouted, interrupting their thoughts. "Can we skip the yapping and focus on the fact we have an enemy who can *rewind time*? I think this might mean we've gotta completely change all our plans up!"

"Not necessarily." Lucifer retorted. "Think about it. Any plan we come up with, he will probably know about. That means if we change plans, we'll only lull ourselves into a false sense of safety. Besides, we don't even know just how potent Cat Mask's powers are. Don't you think they sound a little too convenient? I bet he has several limitations on how he can use them."

"That's right." Auger added. "Human Heroes aren't invincible. Maybe he can only rewind once per day? Maybe he can only go back in time a short period? The fact we know he can rewind time doesn't tell us any of the nuances. If he were using this ability at the most frightening level, he could replay millions of days over and over again, carefully engineering a perfect strategy to uplift humanity and destroy the demons. But right now, we certainly don't seem to be in any major danger. Lucifer, how old is Cat Mask?"

She shrugged. "Ose tells me his real name is Hideki Hiro. I must assume he's in his forties or fifties."

"So it's true then." Satan said, his expression turning into a scowl. "The angels hid the existence of Hideki and Jason real clever-like. They're the blood descendants of Harold Whittaker, and the Heroic Aura has begun passing down through his family tree. The humans must have engineered a way to reverse old Raphael's changes to the Heroic Aura, all those millennia ago."

Satan paused.

"If Hideki or Cat Mask or whatever has some omniscient power to rewind and redo time, then we're fucked no matter what. But I bet his power *does* have limits. The proof is in the pudding, and we demons are still doin' just fine for ourselves. We'll continue the attack on Heaven as planned!"

Satan held up a finger of warning. "But you guys make sure you spread the word around the higher-ups. Let the other Emperors and Dukes know to keep an eye out for Cat Mask. He and the Archseer are certain to show up once blood starts spraying."

"Even if Cat Mask doesn't know what we're planning, and that's a big 'if', don't forget what the Archseer's powers are." Auger pointed out. "He's a Dream Eater. He may have learned our plans by devouring our dreams."

"Then we'll just have to adapt on the fly." Satan growled. "No excuses. We've got way more elites and superior firepower compared to those damn pigeons."

Satan looked around the room at the faces of the other three Emperors.

"This is it, folks. The Day of Reckoning. If we can snag Valac's Lantern, it will all have been worth it. If we fail, hopefully it will only set us back a little."

"Even if the angels know we're coming, it won't change anything." Diablo affirmed. "We have to do this while we still can. The humans have been getting scarier as time goes on."

Lucifer rubbed her third eye. "You're telling me. If Cat Mask shoots me in the fucking eye *one more time*, I swear I'm going to rip his manhood off and shove it up his-"

Auger coughed loudly and spread out his arms. "I will ensure all the Hells stay in contact with one another. Leave that part to me."

"Good. We'll launch the attack in one hour." Satan said. "Move out!"

Inside Heaven, a single solitary figure flew across the vast, seemingly unending sky. That figure was Archangel Raphael.

Heaven was unrecognizable compared to its ancient past. Ever since Satan had detonated his body with the force of an atomic bomb and leveled most of Heaven, Raphael had spent millennia alongside his sister Uzziel rebuilding, strengthening, and expanding Heaven's defenses. Thanks to many layers of spatial strengthening spells, Heaven's dimensional space had been reinforced to such an extent that it usually took Raphael a full five minutes to open a portal to the outside world. Lesser angels needed even more time.

On top of that, Heaven was now bigger than the Earth itself in terms of arable land space. Since angels did not require sustenance to survive, Heaven was able to house many more Lazarites than there were currently people living on Earth. Though, at the moment, there were six billion Lazarites compared to eight billion humans. In perhaps ten or twenty more years, as humans died off and became Lazarites, those numbers would quickly change, but not enough time had passed since the Industrial Revolution, so the clock was still ticking.

Heaven consisted of many great regions, but the most important dynamic was that it was no longer merely angels who lived there. Instead, Titans owned half of Heaven's land,

as per their agreement with the angels following the War in Heaven thousands of years earlier.

Once the demons slaughtered countless angels and Titans, all those years ago, their situation had become precarious. Satan's thermonuclear explosion had killed nearly all the Purebloods, leaving the angels with a frighteningly small population. Thus, moving the few remaining angels and Titans into Heaven became a top priority. Now, millennia later, the angels had replenished their ranks with Lazarites, and the Titans had bred extensively.

In total, there were around twenty million Titans now living in Heaven. They lived simple and secure lives, and each individual Titan owned hundreds of acres of land for themselves. This was excellent mainly because their bodies were large, and unlike the angels, consuming food and sustenance was essential in order for their bodies to grow over time.

Titans were unique among the top super-species on Earth. Demons and humans bred like rabbits. Angels could not reproduce at all. Titans bred much more slowly than the former, but held a decisive advantage over the latter.

Demons gained power by consuming human souls. Angels lost power over time and could only strengthen themselves through human prayer. Humans did not have any reliable means of gaining magical ability, but their technology improved every generation and slowly made them a force that even the demons feared.

But Titans simply grew stronger as time passed and as their bodies aged. A young Titan, less than a hundred years old, was already strong enough to beat an average Demon Lord into the dirt. Titan Kings like Zeus were far stronger than Demon Emperors, and roughly equivalent to the top Archangels. What's more, Titans grew stronger based on the quality of the food they ate. Unlike demons, they did not devour souls to empower themselves, but instead fruits, vegetables, and meat. During the Dragon Wars, Titans could grow much more powerful much more quickly by consuming the flesh of dead dragons, since their bodies were rich in nutrients. But these days, the animals of Earth were not too strong in comparison to the ancient dragons.

Thus, Titans advanced slowly but steadily, and they were considered the true Champions of Heaven. This was a mutually beneficial arrangement made by the leaders of the Titans and Angels. King Zeus was the strongest Titan alive, and he had only grown

mightier following the War in Heaven. Many privately believed he was stronger than all the Archangels, and the thought this might be true had privately caused tensions to slowly simmer beneath the surface.

Why should the Titans be considered equal to the angels... if they were actually superior?

Thus, Raphael flew through the skies to travel to the Hall of Odin, the largest and most prestigious building in all of Jötunheimr, the land of the Titans. As he flew, Raphael passed by giant buildings that rivaled human skyscrapers, each one housing between one Titan and a small family of lesser Titans. These days, the average Titan's height was already close to 200 feet tall, and most of the younger ones stood in excess of 50 feet tall. As for Titan King Zeus himself...

Raphael lifted his eyes to look into the distance. He spotted a gigantic building far bigger than anything the humans had ever build, a super-hall as wide as it was tall, covered in carved murals of ancient Titan Kings, feats of battle the Titans had achieved over the millennia, and even artistic representations of long-forgotten battles during the Primordial Eras. The hall was divided into multiple sub-buildings, but even the smallest ones were 5,000 feet tall. The largest building rose multiple miles into Heaven's sky and could be seen from great distances across Heaven.

This was the Hall of Odin, the most prestigious hall in all of Jötunheimr. It was where Titan King Zeus lived, along with his wife Hera, and a handful of his closest descendants. Living inside the hall was considered a great honor, and few were allowed to do so.

Raphael descended toward the Hall of Odin. He slowed his momentum when he arrived at the entrance, opting to land on the ground despite knowing it would place him in an inferior position. He had to crane his neck backward to look up at the towering statues etched in the visages of dozens of ancient Titan Kings and Queens. Titan Queen Odin's image stood in the main hall, her powerful body towering over all the lesser status, one hand stretched out with her palm aimed at the entrance, warning visitors to be on their best manners lest a tragedy befall them.

Raphael waited at the entrance to the hall. He didn't need to announce his arrival, for the Titans could easily sense his presence from afar.

Before long, the youngest member of the Hall walked inside, a broad smile upon his face. He stood 224 feet tall, his big toe alone dwarfing Raphael's entire body. From on

high, he looked down and smiled smugly in a manner that would have ruffled the feathers of any prideful angel. Luckily, Raphael was in full control of his emotions, and these petty moves did nothing to alter his mental state.

"Archangel Raphael, it is good to see you." The black-haired Titan said, his voice loud but not too boisterous. "My father wondered when you would seek his counsel."

"The demons are at our doorstep, young Apollo." Raphael said. "You know well why I hath traveled so far. Bring me to see the God King."

"Of course, Archangel." Apollo said, turning around to walk inside the hall.

Raphael could not possibly keep up with the lumbering giant by walking, so he instead leaped into the air, flapped his wings, and flew beside Apollo as the Titan led him deeper into the hall.

"How fares Aphrodite these days?" Raphael asked casually. "I hear her beauty has grown to rival even that of sister Uzziel."

"Haha. You have heard well, Archangel Raphael." Apollo said jovially. "My sister is the foremost maiden of the Western Pantheon."

"Verily, my eyes art too aged to appreciate a woman's beauty at any age." Raphael said dismissively. "I hath seen countless vixens and damsels over the eons. A child such as thee cannot fathom the number of beautiful angels who once lived in our galaxy alone. My sister Cassiel, for one."

"Cassiel?" Apollo asked. "I don't think I've heard her name before."

"That is because her era ended long before the mindwipes came into effect." Raphael said mildly.

After traveling for a short while, they reached the rear of Odin's Hall, where they entered a strategic war room. Upon entering, a massive table with a map of Heaven's most prominent realms lay spread out, taking up two or perhaps even three times the floor space of a human skyscraper's base. The table was so massive that most humans would find the hills and mountains of Heaven depicted upon the map to be as large as houses compared to themselves. They would have to walk for a good thirty minutes to cross from one edge of the map to the other!

The war room had many ceremonial weapons and armor pieces placed along the walls to add decoration. These armors were not exactly fragile, but they would certainly prove

useless in the event of a great battle. They were only meant to be worn during rituals such as weddings and other events of that sort. Helmets, armor pieces, gauntlets, greaves, boots, and various spears, swords, shields, and other such accessories lined the walls.

Zeus stood at the other end of the table, along with his wife, Hera. When Raphael entered the Hall of Odin, they sensed his presence and had been waiting for his arrival. As such, they both stood and watched as the tiny winged figure arrived alongside their son.

"Brother Raphael." Zeus said with a polite smile. "We have been awaiting your arrival."

"Hello, Raphael." Hera said, smiling sweetly at him. "It's good to see you again. It's been a few years since you paid us a visit."

Raphael waved his hands. Suddenly, his body started to inflate in size. Within seconds, a physical illusion of himself spread out and began to grow, grow, grow. He rapidly towered above the 224-foot-tall Apollo and erupted upward, growing taller and taller until he approached the height of Zeus himself!

Zeus's smile turned ever so slightly into a frown. As the King of all Titans, his height was important. He stood 479 feet tall, and was approaching the demarcation point of 500, which would signal that he had reached half the height of the most powerful Titan of all time, Odin the Allmother. As for Hera, she was 442-feet tall, and she was among the tallest of her species as well.

Thus, when Raphael grew his false body, he deliberately lifted himself to 475 feet tall, only the slightest bit shorter than the Titan King himself, placing himself virtually on the same pedestal.

Naturally, Zeus was not so discourteous as to point out Raphael's intentions, but it was obvious to everyone present. Apollo glanced at Raphael's back, his expression ugly. Raphael had subtly implied without saying a word that he stood on near-equal footing with Zeus, which thereby implied so did the angels!

These days, that was a slap across the face of the Titans! No Titan believed the angels were capable of matching them anymore. It had not yet become a public point of contention, but privately the Titans believed that they were the true rulers of Heaven now. They were bigger, they had far mightier and more numerous elites, and the tiny insect-like swarms of Lazarites were nothing by comparison! The angels were down to four

Archangels and a few hundred purebloods, and those purebloods were barely worth scoffing at!

Thus, when Raphael finished his expansion and stood practically eye-to-eye with Zeus, his transformation offered a silent but steady element of pushback to dissuade Zeus of any notions of equality. It was clear that Raphael did not believe the angels were weaker than the Titans, and even if they were, it was not by much!

Zeus's nose twitched, but he forced a polite smile as he reached his arm across the table. "It is good that we can speak face-to-face, Raphael. That trick of yours is much better than me having to crane my neck to look down at you."

Down at me, or down *upon* me?" Raphael asked, a fake smile of his own plastered across his face. He reached out his hand and took Zeus's, the two of them exchanging a firm handshake.

"What are you implying?" Zeus asked innocently, frowning slightly as if offended by Raphael's words. "Long have the Titans and angels been friends. Following the destruction of both our species, you gave us a place to stay inside Heaven. We have made it our home and lived alongside you in peace. I would never presume as to look down upon such close friends."

Raphael's smile grew more pointed. He deliberately squeezed Zeus's hand, prompting the King to squeeze back. "Many rumors hath entered my ears over the last few decades. This old man is gladdened to hear those rumors were little more than the chattering of those who are young and stupid. Naturally, the old and wise would not humor such silliness."

After a long moment of holding eye contact, Raphael released his grip, and so did Zeus. Their arms fell to their sides, and Raphael turned his attention to Hera.

"Lady Hera, thy beauty is the same as the falling of autumn leaves. Its coloration only deepens every year."

Hera smiled. "My thanks for your kind words, Raphael. I hope that we may focus on the matter at hand regarding this coming war."

Raphael's smile vanished. He looked at the map of Heaven with great trepidation.

"Heaven's gate is positioned in the Northern Glades." Raphael said, pointing at a forest Uzziel herself had grown thousands of years ago, after Satan's nuclear blast. "I am

uncertain as to what end these demons are attacking us, but this move stinks of desperation. They art only doing so as a result of the new Heroes who have appeared among the humans."

Zeus looked at the profile of Raphael's face for a moment, then lowered his gaze to the war map.

"The most obvious answer is that the demons wish to cause widespread damage to the angels. Specifically, they may wish to assassinate one or more Archangels." Zeus said pointedly. "The next goal they may be pursuing is one of acquisition. Perhaps they wish to raid Camael's artifacts and steal ones they can make use of."

"Not much point in that." Hera spoke. "Most artifacts are infused with holy energy. Demons cannot use them."

"Indeed, but there is one artifact the demons may wish to acquire over the others." Zeus said, raising an eyebrow.

He slid his finger down the map toward the southern area of Heaven, far from the Gate.

"The Lazarus Tower." Raphael said, stroking his beard. "Verily, I suspected this might be the case. A demonic artifact is what allows humans to rise and live as Lazarites. If the demons steal or destroy it, they shalt cripple our war capabilities."

"Then it is good that you have placed the tower in the center of the Titans' strongholds." Zeus said with a smile. "My brothers and sister of the Eastern Pantheon will surely protect it with all their hearts. I will personally place five of my children surrounding the Tower to ensure no demon strike force can draw near."

Hera smirked. "These demons are quite stupid if they think they can seize or destroy the artifact. They would have to battle across a thousand miles of Heaven to even draw within striking distance of the Tower. It is the most heavily fortified location in all our lands."

Raphael didn't appear so dismissive. "There is another possibility. Satan mayeth intend to do what he did in the past: Detonate his body with enough force to obliterate much of Heaven. He hath had millennia to collect more souls than he ever possessed during the first War in Heaven. If so, we shoulds't prevent him from entering Heaven at

all costs. He mayeth make a play for the tower only to draw our eyes away as he positions himself in the center of Heaven, and then..."

Raphael made an 'exploding' motion with his hands, causing Zeus and Hera's expressions to turn ghastly.

"Satan sacrificed just as many of his people as he killed ours, last time." Zeus said, worry on his face. "If he is truly feeling pressured by the appearance of two human Heroes, this suicidal play might actually be a stroke of genius. Even if he loses a few Emperors in the process, the damage done would be incalculable. Now that Heaven surrounds the entire Earth, the aftereffects of such an explosion would certainly devastate the entire planet, causing a mass-casualty event among the humans. If the demons hide their strongest elites underground, they could eliminate as much as half the humans, or more!"

"This must be his objective." Hera said, pressing a finger to her lips. "He wouldn't have done this in the past, but those Heroes have forced his hand! We have to think of a way to force him out of Heaven if he should do such a thing again."

"In the past, when Satan detonated his body, I must confess that I was greatly taken aback and lost my wits in the moment." Raphael admitted. "Had I known he was capable of such a vile act, I would have used all my power to force him out into the Void. Perhaps this is something we must consider now."

Raphael looked deeply at Zeus.

"Brother Zeus. Thy people and mine are not bound to the limits of this planet. Unlike the demons, we may traverse the Void at will. As such, we shoulds't consider the possibility of taking up refuge on another planet. I could even create a new Gate that would connect Heaven to such a world."

Zeus looked surprised. "The Void? The blackness beyond our world? You believe there are other worlds out there suitable for life?"

Raphael chuckled. "The Titans hath fallen far from their peak, King Zeus. But thy people can survive in the Void without much trouble. Thy bodies are no less hardy, and they doth not require but a single breath to spend centuries swallowed by the Void. Naturally, traversing the Void is not a simple matter, and there art billions of worlds one mayeth travel to, but I digress. There are plenty of worlds thou coulds't reach if thy people used their long-forgotten void-traversal abilities properly."

Zeus thought about Raphael's proposal for a while.

"I've never once considered leaving Earth to live elsewhere. But unlike the angels, my people do not require the existence of a lesser species to feed ourselves. If we were to spread among the stars, we could proliferate much more quickly and freely than if we stayed on Earth. The same cannot be said for you."

"Indeed." Raphael admitted. "Our lives art tethered to those of the humans. We require their prayers to sustain us. We hath become quite pitiful over the last few eras. We no longer possesseth the same capacity for glory as we once did in the past."

Zeus pondered Raphael's conundrum. It was an interesting dilemma. Now that he thought about it, Zeus realized that staying on Earth was potentially a ruinously stupid decision! Why stay on Earth when the Titans could just as easily traverse the stars? Why not seek out the land of their ancestors? Could Valhalla be out there, somewhere, hidden among the infinite stars?

But, Zeus realized, if the Titans did leave Earth, the angels would fall. They were no longer strong enough to protect themselves. The Archangels were still mighty, but they had become weaker than during the War in Heaven, and the Archangels of those ancient times were far weaker than their Primordial selves.

Zeus didn't hate Raphael. He didn't loathe the angels or want to see them dead. He merely believed that they were not fit to be called the owners of Heaven any longer. If the angels simply accepted the truth and bowed their heads to him, Zeus was kindhearted enough to let them continue to live in Heaven with no further changes. He would protect them not as superiors or equals, but as his vassals.

Surely, given their sad decline, this was not asking too much? And yet Raphael still proudly acted as though he were the leader of Heaven.

Ahh, how it vexed Zeus greatly and soured his thoughts. He did not wish to step on Raphael's pride, but the fact of the matter was the Titans now towered over the angels in ways both literal and metaphorical. One could say that Raphael was the rightful leader due to his countless years of accumulated knowledge and wisdom, but if the two of them came to blows, Zeus had no reservations about the idea he would soundly trounce the old man.

Should wisdom lead a people, or power? This was the sticking point that always gave Zeus pause. He did not believe that he was a wiser leader than Raphael, and as such, he

held off on starting an ugly battle for leadership. He still felt like a junior in front of the old man. So long as Raphael's control of Heaven did not lead to a tragedy, Zeus could remain cool and allow things to stay the way they were.

But if Raphael should ever slip up...

Zeus cleared his throat. "Let us set aside the matters of departing Earth. My people shall stay here for the immediate future. Defending Heaven is, therefore, our natural priority. I will speak to King Ra to rally his sons and daughters for the coming war. Izanagi and Susanoo will be eager to join from the Eastern Pantheon, while Indra and Yami will join from the Southern Pantheon."

Raphael gave Zeus a long stare. "And the North?"

"...You know as well as I that the Norse are a stubborn lot. They love war and battle, but they do not believe Heaven will be under any major threat. Only Forseti has indicated interest in keeping an eye on the gate. The others think the demons have lost their bite and killing hordes of weaklings is beneath them."

Raphael snorted. "I doth not wish to speak ill of those who art not present, but it feels to me that the Titans hath grown sedentary in recent decades. Too many were born who dids't not witness the horrors of the Ancient Era. They lack a conception of how dangerous our enemies truly art."

"You speak truth, old friend." Zeus said. "But what can we do regarding these matters? Following the War in Heaven, fewer than 100 Titans remained among the living. It is a miracle we've returned to our former glory. The young may have read the lore of old, but they were not there to witness those legends in the making."

"I will see if I can convince more Titans to assist in defending the gate." Hera promised. "Zeus can be a little... standoffish. But the other Titan Kings typically will lower their guard around me."

"The demons mayeth appear tiny and weak, but their combined power is frightening." Raphael warned. "Thou shoulds't taketh this situation as seriously as possible. I am fine with tossing away the lives of countless Lazarites, but if anything mayeth happen to the Lazarus Tower, we shan't have Lazarites to spare in the future."

Zeus's expression became grim. "I know well the importance of the Tower. Say no more, Raphael."

The old Archangel glanced out a window and squinted. "The daylight wanes. Before long, the cover of night shalt arrive. That is when the demons shalt begin their assault on the Gate. I must take my leave."

Raphael nodded at Zeus. He turned to leave, but then Zeus slightly raised his hand.

"Wait, Raphael. Regarding..."

Raphael turned to look at Zeus. "Yes?"

For a brief moment, Zeus and Raphael met each other's eyes. Neither one spoke, and eventually, Zeus lowered his gaze.

"Ah. It's nothing. Let us work together to protect our lands."

"Mmm." Raphael grunted. "Let us do that then."

He turned and walked out of the room, leaving Zeus, Hera, and Apollo alone. Five minutes later, Apollo snorted through his nose.

"Father! Why did you not bring up the matter of transferring leadership? Always, you allow Raphael to push you around!"

Zeus sighed. His expression seemed tired. "You don't understand, child. Raphael is ancient. I may be a Titan King to you, but I am still a child in his eyes. Merely meeting his gaze was enough to break my resolve. It seems in matters of leadership, I am still his inferior."

Hera closed her eyes and shook her head helplessly. "I do not revere Raphael in the way you do. It was his lack of foresight that created the dragons, the Titans, and the demons. How can you continue to treat him as wise and all-knowing when he has blundered so many times?"

"I was not there for the primordial times, so I do not know the circumstances behind the first two." Zeus said. "As for the demons... who can say if what happened was truly Raphael's fault? The burden of command is heavy. He may have been pressured by others to make foolish decisions."

"Pressured? That old croney?" Hera scoffed. "You do not give him enough credit."

"Perhaps not." Zeus admitted.

The Titan King tapped the war table.

"Send a message to Neptune. Inform the Atlanteans that the demons are likely to begin their attack by nightfall. With any luck, we can pincer them with an attack from inside and outside the Gate."

"I pray Neptune will come to our aid." Apollo said, before kneeling and taking his leave.

With Poseidon having long ago died to the machinations of Satan, his son became the leader of Atlantis. Now, they were the only Titans who continued to live outside of Heaven, hidden beneath the depths of Earth's oceans.

Their contribution could end up being paramount in this coming war...

Part 719: Countermeasures Coalescing

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR.

Another day passed in realspace time. The galaxy was changing rapidly, and many events had been playing out across countless worlds.

The Wordsmiths were both dead, Maiura had fallen to the Plague, and Tarus II was destroyed by the Volgrim in a last-ditch attempt to finally eliminate the human threat once and for all. This had left humanity badly weakened and on the brink of destruction.

The Volgrim had lost 95% of their Psions to the machinations of Creator Demila and Demon Deity Mephisto, reducing their war strength to a fraction of what it once was.

The Kolvaxians were revealed to not be a hivemind of unknown origins, but the deliberate creation of Archangel Uzziel as part of her revenge against the demons, Volgrim, and humans.

Emperor Crow had attacked Cassiel and Soleil, ultimately killing the latter before being mercilessly slaughtered by Demon Emperor Gressil. His ploy removed Cassiel's protective detail and brought her to the edge of despair.

On top of everything else, Uriel had been separated from Barbatos's body, but she, Michael, and Gabriel had formed a united front against Raphael and Uzziel, allowing Barbatos to escape and report everything he had seen to the demons, as well as the rest of the galaxy.

So much had happened. So many events had played out that the formerly static and barely changing galactic playing board of the Milky Way from less than a decade earlier had been completely upended. Now, multiple factions were frantically racing to try and pick the pieces back up, conquer new territory, prevent expansion into their existing territory, and simply defend whatever scraps they could.

The galactic situation was not looking good for many disparate species across the Milky Way. The Kolvaxians were united under one ruler. They were numerous and powerful, with no apparent weaknesses. They could traverse the Void at great speeds and infest distant worlds in secret through a method nobody had properly deduced.

On top of all that, the Kolvaxians had gained two immense power-ups in the fact that Artoria's biological essence had raised every Kolvaxian's physical durability to the level of a Middle Cosmic, and that Raphael was now acting as a strategist for the hive itself.

But despite all of this, the slumbering giant known as the combined power of all Sentients across the galaxy... *had not yet given up*.

There was still a fight to be had. Humanity would not bow, and they had made a decision that would set them on the path of leading the other species, despite seemingly being 'weak' and 'useless' without their Wordsmiths...

The world of Pixiv. Humanity's Sole Settlement: Neil City.

"Less than a day, people!" General Chadwick shouted. "Pack only the essentials. Don't worry about food, or water. Only bring along weapons and technology!"

Men and women, soldiers and civilians, children and adults. All the humans on Pixiv hurried to and fro, racing to grab every last item they could, focusing their efforts on bringing along as much wartime munitions, weapons, and armor as possible.

Nobody smiled. Nobody laughed. A pallor of fear and desperation hung in the air. But mixed with the negativity, there was also a grim determination.

Humanity had originally planned to live on Sharmur and Pixiv, separate from one another. Many humans still believed in human supremacy, especially those among Jepthath's Legion. They did not want to fight or live alongside demons. As such, they had moved to the Fairy homeworld, intending to make a new life there.

But now, barely three weeks after being uprooted from Maiura, they were once again moving their belongings, a sense of despair in their hearts.

How many times would they become refugees? How many more times would they have to uproot their lives as if tearing hair from a scalp?

The common people didn't know what was going on. Their leaders assured them this was a good thing, and their lives were about to improve, but nobody truly believed this to be the case.

Even though the humans were transferring to Sharmur, the fairies were not. In fact, the fairies insisted on remaining behind, even after Commander Chadwick privately

briefed Fairy Queen Calanthra on the new plan. He thought it was obvious the fairies would be better off taking up refuge inside the Cube.

Instead, Calanthra had merely smiled and told them to take the humans away. If the Cube could come to swallow up Pixiv directly, then that would be acceptable, but under no circumstances would she allow the fairies to abandon Pixiv to the Plague. As for her reasons why, she would not say, leaving some among the human leadership to wonder...

General Chadwick marched around the Warpgate, barking orders at various groups of personnel. He told them which boxes of goods to take first and which to save for the last day. Eventually, he stopped for a short coffee break, and to speak with someone important.

"Henry!" Chadwick shouted, causing the young man to turn and look at him. The two men stood inside a tent less then 500 meters from the Warpgate. "What has she decided?"

Henry nodded. He walked toward a table in the center of the tent, where a starmap of the Milky Way was laid out.

"This is the Southern Sector." Henry said, marking out the bottom 'quarter' of the Milky Way. "You can see the Plague-controlled worlds encroaching on the east and west edges here and here. There are thirty Plague-controlled worlds inside the Southern Sector's borders located here, here, and here. Maiura is one of them."

He drew several lines between various dots on the map. It was a map the Volgrim had given humanity, one which positioned the galaxy in a semi-flat way, with a chosen cardinal direction to be the Galactic North. As the galaxy rotated, the stars stayed in vaguely the same relative positions, but the universe outside would also rotate, so there was a Galactic North for mapping the interior of the Milky Way, and a Universal North that always pointed toward the origin point of the universe. These two Norths were completely different from one another.

The northern, eastern, and western sectors of the Milky Way were almost entirely controlled by the Kolvaxians. These days, aside from a few scattered worlds barely within the southernmost edges of the East Sector and West Sector, the Volgrim had fully fallen back to the Southern Sector, and the Plague were already starting to nibble at the Southern Sector. With the loss of the Psions, the Southern Sector's fate was looking increasingly dire.

"This is where the ruins of Ancient Earth are located, roughly 26,000 lightyears (ly) from the galactic center, near the end of this spiral arm. And this star here? That's Sharmur, roughly 9,500ly west of Earth."

"This is Pixiv. You can see it's about 2,300ly northwest of Sharmur. In galactic terms, a stone's throw. Look over here. The Tarus system is 7,200ly east of Sharmur, and Hell Harbor is another 9,300ly east of the Tarus system. The Cube started out in Hell Harbor, and was moved west by Jason until it came to a rest in the Tarus system, where it remained until the planet's destruction. It can travel roughly 1,500ly per day at max speed, so to get it from the Tarus system to the Sharmur system would require..."

"A little less than five days." Chadwick answered, doing quick calculations in his head. "It's been eighteen days since the Cube departed, so it should have already arrived inside the Sharmur system..."

Henry shook his head. "Not quite. The Cube's travel speed is quite fast at max speed, even compared to Volgrim starships, but much slower than High Psions who specialize in Spatial Psionics. At Warp 8.0, a Volgrim starship would take just over a week to travel the 7,200 lightyears between Tarus II and Sharmur, or it would take a little more than three days at Warp 8.1. Thus, we can say the Cube is capable of traveling at top speeds between Warp 8.0 and 8.1."

He continued. "The problem is, to maintain secrecy, the Cube had to take a more roundabout route, making it move at a speed comparable to Warp 7.5. Still, it will arrive within the next twelve hours, thus the difference isn't too large."

Henry pointed at Sharmur with his left index finger, and the destroyed Tarus system with his right index finger.

"The Cube does not strictly travel at any level of Warp Speed. Instead, it travels at Lightspeed through the dimension called P-Space, where distances between stars are far, far smaller. It has to avoid the gravity well of stars, black holes, and other such stellar phenomena, so its speed isn't as constant as a Volgrim ship traveling at standard Warp Speed."

A short moment passed as Chadwick gave Henry a long look. "This is good to know and everything, but what does this have to do with Linda's decision?"

The greater point of their meeting was not to casually discuss interstellar distances, but to instead discuss what actions humanity should take after the Cube arrived inside the

Sharmur system. Thus, Henry's expression became solemn.

"Our immediate goal is to place the entire Sharmur system inside the Cube. The problem is, we don't know whether or not this will damage Demon Deity Melody, or maybe even kill her. If all goes well, we can move the system inside the Cube and gain a Middle Cosmic powerhouse to defend the Cube. But if things go wrong, Melody will die, and humanity will lose our strongest protective talisman."

Henry continued. "Let's assume everything goes badly, Commander. The Cube swallows the Sharmur system and Melody suffers catastrophic damage or even dies. The decision of what to do next is easy. We will have confirmed that the Cube cannot preserve the power of Stellar Wardens, and thus we would only cause damage by trying to swallow their systems. We would move on to Pixiv, which is a short 2300 lightyears away, and within a day and a half, we would scoop up the Fairies and add them to the Cube's internal worlds. Beyond that, we would simply have to pray the Plague hadn't noticed our actions, or else adding other worlds to the Cube would become impossible."

The two men looked at one another, giving Henry a moment to collect his thoughts. However, it was Chadwick who spoke next.

"I understand now. If the Cube can preserve Melody's power, then that would prove we could do the same for the other Stellar Wardens. Those Demon Deities would become powerful assets if we merged them into the Cube. Thus, going to Pixiv next might not be the best idea."

Henry hesitated. "...If the problem only involved empowering humanity and making us more fit to fight the Plague, the decision would be easy. But it isn't."

Darkness fell over Chadwick's eyes. "Mmm. Because of trust."

"Because of trust." Henry confirmed. "Even if the Cube can preserve a Warden's power, do we really trust the Demon Deities enough to add one, two, or perhaps even more of them into the Cube? After all the things they've done? Maybe it's my inner Jepthath talking, but I don't trust those scumbags as far as I can toss them."

"My opinions are obvious." Chadwick said, his voice low. "Nobody on Pixiv trusts the demons. Many people are angry they have to pack up and leave. I would prefer we just stick to the plan of adding Sharmur and Pixiv to the Cube and just leave these demons to themselves."

"You would still have to place your trust in Melody though." Henry pointed out.

"Of course. But I don't mind her much, and I believe she's proven her loyalties decently well. She's gone to bat for humanity several times already." Chadwick said. "Besides, what choice do we have? Melody and Beelzebub are our only powerful protectors. We must rely on them, at least for now."

The young man squeezed his superior's shoulder gently. Henry sighed. "With no Wordsmiths, we're low on options. I pray the Wordsmith's children are able to rise to the challenge. Of Hope's three children, I think Mandy has the best shot of assisting us on a strategic level. Her Runic powers are great for making powerful artifacts, weapons, and armor. Levi is a solid frontline fighter, but when the enemies are Cosmics, I don't think he'll be able to do much. Blake is young and inexperienced, but he certainly has potential."

Chadwick touched his chin. "What about Jason's son? Timothy? Shouldn't he be around... oh, I don't know... 16 years old by now?"

"I can't say for certain, but I think he's closer to 18 or 19 now." Henry said. "Jepthath doesn't have any Legionnaires inside Chrona, so we can't communicate directly with them. Our best bet is that the fairies can establish communication with Blinker, or maybe Marie Becker can get in contact with her Cybernite liason."

"We don't even know if Timothy has powers." Chadwick said. "It's best not to rely on an unknown variable. We should work with what we know we have. It's entirely possible Timothy won't get any powers at all."

A short lull in the conversation followed. Henry communication with the Legion for a minute or so, then his expression darkened.

"Something's been bothering me, Chadwick."

Chadwick's eyebrows shot up. "What's the matter?"

The Norwegian man's portly body shook as he noticed Henry's unease.

"Remember how Jason Hiro supposedly removed the 'flaw' from human bodies?" Henry asked.

"Of course." Chadwick responded. "It's made our people able to impregnate basically any species."

"Right... and as weird as that is, that's all we've really seen happen." Henry pointed out. "I thought removing the Flaw was supposed to give us Heroes galore, but so far nothing has really happened. Demons like Kiari have become impregnated by human lovers, but beyond that, not much has changed. We don't see any powerful new Heroes rising up. We don't see incredible feats happening. Everything just seems... the same."

Chadwick stared down at the galactic map laid out on the table. His eyes bored into it with deep intent, yet his gaze was unfocused, as if he couldn't see anything in front of him in particular.

"It hasn't even been a month yet." Chadwick concluded. "Perhaps not enough time has passed for humans to develop any powers. Perhaps our current generation won't be able to develop any abilities, but the next one will."

"You might be right, but the uncertainty is killing me." Henry complained. "We NEED champions. Now more than ever. The Archangels deceived us, and they're going to gobble up the whole galaxy if we don't fight back."

"The situation is dire, but I do not believe it's hopeless." Chadwick said with a knowing smile. "We are not yet backed into a corner. If the only thing we do is place the Sharmur system inside the Cube, and even if Melody dies, I believe that as long as we hide the Cube in a corner of the galaxy and increase its time dilation, we will be able to advance rapidly. Who knows? Perhaps we may even be able to develop a single star system to the point humanity alone can fight back the Plague!"

Henry didn't seem to buy into Chadwick's argument. "The situation *is* 'hopeless.' Hope literally died. I don't see humanity making it another decade, let alone a hundred years."

"Oh, ye of little faith." The Commander said with a snort. "Just take it from a tired old man. Humanity is not so weak that we will bow to the Plague."

After a minute of wrapping up the discussion, Chadwick pointed at the map.

"Tell Linda my recommendation is to swallow the Sharmur system, then the Pixiv system, no matter what. As for the Demon Deities, we should only determine whether or not to swallow one or more of their systems after we have saved our closest allies first."

"Alright." Henry said. "I'll pass that on to her."

The young man turned and strode out of the tent, leaving Chadwick behind. The Norwegian man snorted derisively.

"Neil was right. We mustn't trust the demons any more than is necessary."

The world of Numaria, deep underground, beneath a mountain.

Barbatos's body twitched. Beside him, Emperor Belial stood, her hands placed upon his chest, pouring her feeble mortal healing energy into him. Emperor Leeroy was there as well, and the two of them worked tirelessly to do their best to heal Barbatos's grievous wounds as best as they could.

"Brother Barbatos." Auger said, as he walked over to stand on the opposite side of the bed Barbatos had been laid upon. "There is a matter I must consult with you about."

Barbatos slowly opened his eyes. A deep gloominess filled his vision; the result of witnessing his brother's death, and the sadness and loneliness that came along with it. For the entire past day after crash-landing on Numaria, his mind had ached with mental pain far greater than the torture his body endured. To lose the only brother he ever had in the world, a brother who had once given his life to save Barbatos, that fact seared his soul's very foundation.

Barbatos was in more pain than anyone knew, but he never let it show.

"Speak..." Barbatos rasped.

Auger hesitated, seeing the pain in Barbatos's eyes. But he ultimately relented. "I have spoken to the Volgrim. They informed me of a possible way we demons might be able to stand a chance against the Plague, but... it would require the help of a High Cosmic, or even better, an Apex Cosmic."

Barbatos slowly blinked. His eyes slid to the left to look at Auger's face. He said nothing, simply waiting for Auger's explanation.

Sensing Barbatos's intent, Auger cleared his throat, bowed his head, and serenely clasped his hands together in front of his waist.

"Unarin believes it may be possible to relocate the star systems of our Middle Cosmics. To do so would require the power of a being terrifying beyond belief. By moving not only the star itself, but also the planets, we might be able to slowly 'drag' Numaria, Hell Harbor, and other such systems together, within just a few lightyears of each other. Middle Cosmics are barely powerful enough to 'nudge' the direction of a system's natural travel orientation, but High Cosmics can exert enough power to directly pull systems in a

desired direction much more quickly. Apex Cosmics would be able to do the same feat, but far faster and with less effort."

Barbatos's eyes opened and closed, ever so slowly.

"You wish... for me... to move Numaria?"

"Not now. You are injured and weak." Auger said, bowing his head. "I would certainly not presume to order you around. I have spent the past 16 hours testing out the range I can project my power. I can travel up to 10 lightyears from Numaria's star before my power begins to wane. Once I travel 15 lightyears, my power starts to drop rapidly, and as such, I believe 10 lightyears is my maximum 'force projection distance.'"

Auger continued. "I have not yet spoken to the other Deities about this, as I wanted to run it past you first. You are the strongest demon in the Milky Way, and as such, everyone is looking to you for leadership. Do you believe, once you are recovered, you will have the strength to move our star systems together? If we can position ourselves closely enough, all the Demon Deities will be able to multiply our power and cover for one another! We will be able to fight back if the Plague arrives and carve out at least one small, tiny sliver of the Milky Way as a bulwark the Archangels won't be able to penetrate!"

Auger paused.

"All of this, of course, is only possible if you are willing to assist us once you've healed. If not... I will continue to look into other alternatives."

A long silence followed. Barbatos's eyes drifted open and closed. He stared up at the ceiling, feeling Belial and Leeroy's healing magic slowly healing his broken body, a little bit at a time.

"Very... well..." Barbatos said quietly. "Once I am... healed. I will try."

Auger's gaze brightened.

"Many thanks, Barbatos. I will do everything in my power to speed up your healing."

He bowed his head respectfully, then turned and walked away.

Now, it seemed possible that the demons had acquired an alternative method of protecting themselves...

Part 720: The Lord of Heroes

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Inside the Hall of Heroes.

Another several months had passed for the denizens living within the Hall of Heroes. In that time period, something remarkable had happened. The outside world had undergone a major upheaval, one which played out in slow motion for Levi, Mandy, and Blake, along with everyone else living inside the secret realm.

The humans, demons, and Volgrim had been forced to work together! This was not a casual partnership, but a deep one borne of extreme urgency.

The Archangels had revealed their betrayal, and Barbatos had made it known how deep Raphael's treachery went.

As such, the people inside the Hall of Heroes now faced a difficult decision.

It was inside an ornate ceremonial hall Solomon had personally built that a group of people had clustered together in anticipation of a formal ceremony. The Hall of Riches was gaudy like every other thing Solomon built, riddled with tacky diamond-studded statues, vases, an organ for playing music, and many chandeliers and candelabras; all colored gold, of course. The room flickered with firelight, but the natural bright white glow of the Hall of Heroes was omnipresent enough to drown out the firelight.

"Young Levi." Hammurabi said, standing beside three of the most senior-ranking Trueborn Ancestors, including Jepthath, Arthur, and Elizabeth Kindelmann. "With your father's passing, you are now the oldest living Trueborn in the Milky Way. In the past, there was only ever one Trueborn, but now that there are multiple, we Ancestors believe that you should be the one to make decisions on all our behalf's."

Levi stood across from the five Trueborn ancestors, a ceremonial altar placed between them. On his right stood his sister, Mandy, and on his left stood his younger brother, Blake. Curiously, much further off to the left there was another individual standing, one whose cold and 90%-robotic body was somewhat unnerving to look at, yet she was also someone who was always polite and never overbearing. She was the Celestial Designer, Psymin Miralax.

"Thank you for your vote of confidence." Levi said, dipping his head politely toward Hammurabi. "I don't know if I'm the right person for the job, though. Just because I'm the oldest of my siblings doesn't mean I'm the best person to be our leader."

Levi had spent another 20 realspace days inside the Hall of Heroes. At a dilation ratio of 100-to-1, that meant about another 2,000 HoH-days, or about five and a half years. He was now 55 years old. His sister was 35, and Blake was 21.

"If we were to choose based on who we thought would be the best strategist, we would probably pick Mandy." Hamuurabi said, smiling at the younger woman. "But Mandy is a very busy woman. Every day, she advances her Runecrafting abilities by leaps and bounds. She should spend as much time as possible working on scraping together every single advantage humanity can get in the coming years. Naturally, Blake is quite young and not the ideal candidate to become leader of the Hall of Heroes, but more importantly, he is constantly working to improve his affinity to light and dark magic. Compared to your two siblings, you are... less occupied."

Neither of Hope's children looked offended by Hammurabi's words. He was only speaking the truth. Levi mostly just trained his body every day, fighting powerful machines made by Psymin which his sister empowered with her Runic Arcs, and training alongside Blake to help him become a more capable fighter. But outside that, Levi didn't have many hobbies.

"...Alright. Fine, I'll accept the position. But I'm going to need to rely on the rest of you." Levi said blandly. "I'm not much of a... book-smarts guy."

"We will offer our counsel, but always defer the final decision to you." Hammurabi said.

In unison, he and the other ancestors formally bowed to Levi.

"We recognize the presence of the new Lord of Heroes, Levi Hiro." Hammurabi said, crossing his hand over his heart. He raised his head back up and smiled. "It's not much of a ritual, but who gives a damn about such matters anyway? It's only us here."

Levi chuckled. He didn't really care about formality. He took after his father in that way.

Blake also laughed, then lightly socked Levi's arm. Levi playfully punched him back. Mandy rolled her eyes at their antics.

After a few moments, Hammurabi's expression became solemn again.

"The reason I invited you three here, as well as Psymin Miralax, is because we have an important decision to make, and I want you to make it, Levi. As we speak, the Founders have suspended all hostilities with humanity, and so have the demons. With these new revelations regarding Archangel Raphael and his plot to seize the Milky Way, we must claw at every possible resource at our disposal. We no longer have Wordsmiths who can 'magic up' powerful artifacts and raw materials at will."

Levi cocked his head. "I'm not quite following."

"Wait, Hammurabi..." Blake said, his eyebrows raising as he glanced at Psymin and seemed to realize why she was invited. "Are you saying... we need to pull the Technopaths my dad captured out of cryostasis?"

Psymin Miralax's expression did not change. She looked at Blake, then she looked at Hammurabi, waiting for confirmation.

The ancient ancestor, now considered the wisest person in the Hall of Heroes after Solomon's death, simply closed his eyes and bobbed his head.

"You've guessed correctly, young Blake. I was once in support of your father's actions, but after the atrocities he committed and his execution of my pupil, Solomon, as well as that kind-hearted Jeremiah fellow, I have begun to look back on his decisions with a more critical eye. I no longer believe the attack on Serris and the subsequent destruction of the planet was a wise choice. Thankfully, he did not actually take any lives. He placed all the Technopaths and other entities from Serris in stasis within the Hall of Heroes. And *that* now gives us a unique opportunity."

Arthur stepped forward. "We Ancestors have unanimously come to an agreement. We believe it would be wise to discreetly inform Unarin that his Technopath researchers are safe with us. We then wish to transport them to the Phoenix's Cube in a few months, once she absorbs the Sharmur system. Those Technopaths will supercharge humanity's engineering and allow us to create weapons of war much more quickly and efficiently than we could ever do with our own limited manpower and knowledge. Additionally, it will help mend relations with the Volgrim Empire."

Levi's smile slowly turned to a frown. "You want to make amends with them? That's ridiculous! The Volgrim attacked Tarus II! They destroyed it! They killed millions of humans! They even killed uncle Jason!"

Mandy nodded. "I agree. This decision is a fine tactical decision, but it's the Volgrim who should be making amends with us, not the other way around. They owe us reparations for all the atrocities they've committed."

"That was then, and this is now." Hammurabi said slowly. "The Total Rendition of Tarus II was a war crime without a doubt. It was abominable. But we are facing extinction. Not just humanity, but the demons, the Volgrim, and all the monster species scattered across the Milky Way."

Elizabeth Kindelmann intervened. "If I may? I believe Mandy makes a fair point. The Volgrim do owe us reparations, and that's exactly what we're going to get. However, from Unarin's perspective, he may have guessed, but could not have definitively known, that Hope had only pretended to kill all the Volgrim on Serris. If Hope truly did kill them, then that could be seen as a preemptive strike and a sign of things to come. Let's not forget that Hope then went to Volgarius to attack Unarin directly. These signs, among others, point to an unstable element that, at the time, threatened Volgarius. From Unarin's perspective, we attacked first, and he retaliated."

"We are going to obtain reparations." Hammurabi said, turning his head to smile and nod at Elizabeth approvingly before turning back to Levi and the rest. "By making these Technopaths serve us, we will put them to work and make them useful. Of course, this is only if you approve, Lord Levi. If not, we can leave them as they are. I simply believe in this critical time, we need to use every resource we have at our disposal."

Levi's frown deepened. His father might not be looked upon favorably by the Ancestors anymore, and for good reason, but as Hope's oldest son, Levi felt it was disrespectful of his father's memory to simply release all those Technopaths Hope had deliberately imprisoned. After all, those Technopaths had committed terrible sins, testing on human subjects and torturing countless human clones to death all for the sake of their Cleansed Mud project, among others.

Mandy, likewise, was able to put aside her feelings and rationally decide that it was a good course of action, but she didn't like the thought of letting them go either. It felt disrespectful to her father's memory, and it made her visibly uncomfortable.

It was at this moment of uncertainty that Blake spoke up.

"I think it's a good idea."

Immediately, Levi and Mandy turned their heads to look at their brother. Now twenty-one years old, he was a young adult, not the immature kid from just a few years before. The death of his father and abrupt disappearance of his mother had traumatized him and forced him to grow up. There was an unmistakable darkness in his eyes, but also a gleam of light. He straddled the line between both states, vowing to become a valiant warrior like his father once was, and like King Arthur himself. At the same time, he struggled with the pain of losing his parents before he had even become an adult. No child could endure something like that without suffering mental scars...

"You do?" Levi probed, testing his brother's conviction.

"I do." Blake said. "Aren't you guys sick of it all? This constant fighting? These endless wars? Our dad died because Jason killed him. Jason killed him because dad attacked him. Dad attacked Jason because he was fucked up in the head. And he was fucked up in the head because of Gressil's torture! If you keep following the string of events, it's just one person treating another person like shit, over and over again, with no end in sight!"

Blake lifted his chin. "I want to put an end to the cycle of violence. I want to choose forgiveness. We can't stop the coming war. We can't just ask the Archangels to play nice. But we can forgive the Technopaths and set an example for them. We can show them that despite their crimes against humanity, we're willing to give them a pass, just this one time, provided they agree to change their ways."

The light flickered in Blake's eyes, momentarily replaced with a simmering darkness.

"And if they refuse to play along? If they repeat their past actions and return to their vile ways? There will be no further forgiveness. We'll execute them all, deservedly this time. This is fair. This is just."

Levi stared at the side of his younger brother's face. He was surprised by what he saw. Levi wasn't much of a high-minded idealist. He wasn't stupid, but he also wasn't much of a thinker. He liked to beat the shit out of other entities with his fists. That was the main reason why he thought becoming the 'Lord of Heroes' wasn't right. He didn't feel cut out for the job.

But in that moment, listening to Blake's words, Levi felt that maybe, in time, the Hall of Heroes would have a better Lord of Heroes. That time wasn't now; it couldn't *be* now. But in the future, when Blake was older and the Ancestors looked upon him more

favorably, who could say? Maybe Levi would be able to pass off his duties and go back to his punching bags, free of the burden of leadership.

After mulling it over for a few moments, Levi turned back to Hammurabi and nodded. "Alright. Blake convinced me. Let's contact Unarin and inform him that we had all the Technopath researchers from Serris, and that we will be deploying them inside the Cube. Of course, we'll keep a relatively small number here inside the Hall of Heroes, if only to support our own needs for high technology."

For the first time, Psymin Miralax spoke. As always, her words were slow, halting, and robotic.

"**I will not stay. I will go. The Cube. Along with the others. Celestial Designer. My knowledge. Put to better use.**"

Levi felt a little hesitant about that, but he decided to relent. "...Very well. Assuming all goes well and the Phoenix successfully transplants Sharmur and maybe Pixiv inside the Cube, I'll initiate transportation between the Hall of Heroes and the Cube."

He turned to Jepthath. "Great Illuminator. Please begin informing Unarin of our intentions. Let him know what we've discussed here, and relay his words back to us. Mandy, spin up the teleportation platform to send one of the Legionnaires over to Volgarius. We need to get this done as quickly as possible."

"That is inadvisable." Jepthath quickly interrupted. "We must not take any chances of Raphael learning that we have a Celestial Designer and several million high ranking Technopaths at our disposal. We should use a slightly slower but safer method of communication with the First Founder."

"What method?" Mandy asked.

"Leave the details to me." Jepthath said. "I will contact a third party and have them transmit the relevant information to Unarin in a way Archangel Raphael cannot possibly intercept. If we teleport a Legionnaire to Volgarius directly, we may inadvertently reveal knowledge of our intentions, assuming Raphael has a way to spy on the Volgrim Founders."

This was a logical decision. After all, Jason had spied on the Volgrim with his Spynet, and Hope had done so as well, albeit a bit less effectively, due to his much more limited Wordsmithing abilities. For an old schemer like Raphael, spying on the Founders would

be a smart thing to do. The only question was whether or not he had the capability, and that was something only he knew.

With this decision complete, the Ancestors finally departed, leaving the three siblings alone inside the meeting room. Well, mostly alone, except Psymin also stayed behind.

The Celestial Designer casually walked over to Blake. She scanned him with her irises, directing the same deadpan stare at him that she always used.

"**Your words. Created a wave. My appreciation. Limitless. You have a good heart. An old friend. You remind me of him. Passed away. Long ago.**"

Blake looked at Psymin in surprise. Despite her cold and harsh robotic tone, he had spent several years around her, and had gotten to know her decently well. She was not usually this chatty, and typically kept to herself.

"Well... I just think it's the right thing to do." Blake said after a moment of thought. "If nobody breaks the cycle of violence, then it will continue on and on, forever, without end. I just want to see an end to the Milky Way's constant wars, even if that's a childish dream."

Psymin glanced at Levi. Then her eyes lowered back to Blake, who was a little shorter than his dragon-blooded brother.

"**Your words. Like Unarin.**" Psymin said slowly. "**Young. But much wisdom. Pacified the Ancient Volgrim Leaders. Those were his methods. Similar sentiments.**"

Psymin turned her head to the side thoughtfully.

"**Politics. Diplomacy. Scheming. Tricks. I am not adept. Creation. Building. Tinkering. I am adept. I enjoy. My body. Pained. My mind. Sharp. Every day. I am tortured. This metal body. Like barbed shackles. Still I persist. Because I must. Because it is my duty.**"

She returned her vision to the trio of siblings.

"**I am glad. Many friends. I wish to see them again. I feared. Never would see again. My position. Lofty. Lonesome at the top. Few understand. Few can comprehend. Many look up to me. Few meet my gaze. Even fewer remain.**"

Blake's eyes softened. "You're... lonely?"

"**My condition. Not severe. Not acute.**" Psymin said. "**The pain. Always there. Faint. Unmistakable. My age. Ancient. My friends. Once numerous. Now barely countable. Most dead.**"

Her tone conveyed no emotion, but her words certainly did. Levi and Mandy both gazed at Psymin in a new light. She might seem like an unfeeling robot, but it was clear that in spite of her roboticization, there was still a thinking, feeling entity hidden deep within. Unable to emote anymore. Unable to express her sorrow. Someone whose inner self had been slowly stripped away over millions of years until she had been literally turned into a shell of a Sentient.

Psymin had silently been dealing with the pain of wondering whether the few people she considered her friends, those who had been working on Serris, would be trapped in stasis forever. Now, thanks to Blake's plea for mercy, they were going to be released.

She was unable to properly express how happy this development made her feel. But Blake understood. Levi understood. And so did Mandy.

After all, they were human. They could easily empathize.

Blake swallowed heavily. He lowered his eyes.

"I'm... sorry my father put your friends in stasis. If I had known how badly it was making you feel, I'd have pushed to release them sooner."

"**No.**" Psymin said. "**Apology unnecessary. The timing. Not right. The timing now. Right. Allies before. Unlikely. Allies now. Possible. What I wish to see. You have made happen. I am thankful.**"

For some reason, Blake started to tear up. Despite her monotone voice, despite her lack of any emotional body language, Blake still felt deep pangs of sympathy welling up within himself. He took a step toward Psymin, uncertain. Then, purely on instinct, he walked toward her and outstretched his arms.

"If... if you want..." Blake said carefully. "I'd like to be your friend, Psymin. I also... really feel... like hugging you right now. But uh, that's probably, uh, weird to you. Never mind."

He started to lower his arms. But before he could fully lower them, Psymin looked directly into his eyes. Her robotic pupils whirred and clicked.

After the briefest of instants, Psymin also stepped toward him. She clumsily lifted her own arms, and took him into her embrace. Mandy and Levi's jaws fell slightly agape as they observed this interaction.

For some reason, they almost felt as if... Blake had just adopted a dog? It wasn't exactly the right feeling, but even despite Psymin's clumsy and robotic movements, it was still incredibly sweet the way Blake and her hugged one another.

The two of them were roughly the same height. They fit into each other's arms perfectly, though to Blake, it felt as if he were hugging a refrigerator. He stifled a sob and a giggle at that absurd thought, then lightly patted Psymin's hardened alloy backside.

The two hugged for several long seconds before pulling apart. Blake quickly wiped his eyes and smiled at Psymin, but her expression remained the same.

He didn't resent her for not showing emotion. If anything, it only made him feel worse. He could feel the sincerity in her movements from that single hug. He swore he could sense her loneliness and desolation.

Blake was young, even by human standards. He could not fathom Psymin's age, or what she had gone through over millions of years of life. She was around the same age as Unarin and Dosena, and had existed during those ancient Great Wars, along with many other Volgrim.

He truly felt it was a shame. Why had she slowly lost her sentient traits? Her love and compassion? Her emotions? Why had she, when Unarin and the other Founders had not? What had forced her to adopt this cold, mechanical shell of a body?

He wanted to ask, but deemed the questions inappropriate, and wisely chose to save them for a later time, when the two were closer than they were now.

"I'm glad to be your friend, Psymin." Blake said, smiling while rubbing the tears out of his eyes in embarrassment. "Sorry for getting all emotional."

"**No. Your emotions are fine.**" Psymin said. "**I am unable. You must express. In my absence. Of course. Our current friendship. Shallow. But over time. Deepen?**"

"Yeah! Definitely." Blake said, smiling at her even more brightly while looking back at his brother and sister. "What are you two waiting for? I'm sure she'd love to have you guys as friends too!"

Levi chuckled. He wasn't the emotional type, but even he felt touched by Blake's earnest attitude. As for Mandy, she thought this new development was an unexpected but welcome surprise. She and Levi walked over and gave Psymin a hug as well.

The relationship between Hope's children and one of the last Celestial Designers had deepened considerably. Only time would tell how well their friendship would flourish.

Naturally, they were not Psymin's 'equal' in most ways, but they had wordlessly agreed to treat her as one, not looking up to or down at her. They would not treat her as an unknowable ancient entity, unfeeling and uncaring, but as a person with thoughts and feelings who needed emotional support even when it seemed she was perfectly fine.

Like this, a subtle but important change occurred inside the Hall of Heroes. It was one nobody in the outside world knew of, and few would understand the significance of...

Part 721: Second Chances

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Inside the Hall of Heroes.

A few weeks passed after Levi's commencement ceremony. Things returned to normal, relatively speaking, except now Blake found himself spending more time with Psymin Miralax than he ever had in the past.

It wasn't constant. Maybe an hour every day or so. But they talked about various things. He learned a little more about her, and she learned a little more about him. One thing remained constant though; Psymin never went into any great detail about her ancient history. She didn't discuss the Great Wars of the Volgrim's past eras, and she didn't discuss what life was like for her in her youth.

Mainly, they talked about their passions. Psymin deeply enjoyed creating technology, to the point it seemed if she ever lost her ability to do so, she would probably end her own life. Blake wasn't much of a tech guy, but he knew a bit and wanted to at least try and learn to connect more deeply with Psymin. He found that using his light and dark magic, he could even summon crude technological devices, so long as they were extremely simple. They would only maintain cohesion so long as he focused, and would disappear afterward.

Sometimes, Blake wished he could upgrade his brain so he could learn more things and think better. Then he would be able to relate to Psymin better, and use his powers more adeptly.

It was on a random Wednesday in the Hall of Heroes when Blake found himself sitting in the central garden. He wasn't doing much. Merely staring at a pond full of fish, watching them as they swam, lost in nostalgic memories of his childhood.

That was when someone spoke, interrupting his thoughts and shaking him from his stupor.

"Lad. What's on your mind?"

Blake blinked. He lifted his gaze and looked to the left, where he saw Arthur sitting down on a rock not far from him. Arthur wore a comfortable white shirt with brown pants

and some simple sandals. He didn't look much like a Hero King, but he still had the bearing of a mystical powerhouse.

"Oh. Hi, Arthur." Blake said, faintly smiling. "Not much. I was just thinking... about my mom and dad."

His smile lacked any warmth. It was merely for appearances, and even by that standard, it seemed quite hollow.

"Solomon too." Blake added after a moment. "And Jeremiah. We've lost a lot of people. I... don't know how to deal with it all. It hurts to think about."

Arthur nodded. His eyes lowered to the grassy, flower-covered ground.

"When Sentients die, if their souls are are somehow captured, they can revive one more time. Sometimes as an undead, sometimes as a heroic phantasm, or perhaps by using the methods the Volgrim do. But if their souls aren't captured at all, they go to the great Beyond, where they pass through the membrane of reality and can never be recovered. It is the final resting place for all souls. And if they revive once, they can never revive again."

A strand of grass found its way into Blake's grasp. He casually wound it around his finger, then unwound it, then rewound it again.

"So we can't bring Solomon or Jeremiah back?" Blake asked.

"No." Arthur said simply. "And their fates were... worse than simply dying. Like humans who ended up devoured by demons, they did not pass on to the Great Beyond. They were completely shattered and... consumed by your father."

"I'm sorry." Blake said quietly.

"Don't be. I don't blame you for your father's actions. Neither do any of the other Heroes. Your father went mad. His actions were a sin of the highest order. I don't know what broke his mind and made him go to such lengths, but if I must blame anyone, then I blame myself. I control the power of the strongest artifact. I could have rebelled and perhaps prevented Solomon and Jeremiah's deaths. But I didn't..."

Arthur leaned forward. He rested his elbows on his knees and clasped his hands together while heavily bowing his head. He didn't look at Blake at all.

"I should have seen it coming." Arthur repeated. "But I didn't. I never do. Not in life, nor in death. That is why I am the Greatest Sinner."

"That's... an unfortunate title." Blake said, looking at the side profile of Arthur's face. "You don't need to demean yourself like that."

"Oh, but I do." Arthur said, chuckling derisively. "My sins are too many to count. Did I ever tell you the manner in which I died?"

Arthur lifted his head slightly to glance at Blake's eyes. The young man slowly shook his head in response.

"No..."

"Then I'll spare you the details." Arthur said softly, looking back down at the ground in shame. "But, in summary... the demons assassinated someone close to me. Someone precious who I loved from the bottom of my heart. I... I went insane with rage. My vision turned red, and I immediately took off without thinking."

Arthur paused. His voice became a little raspy.

"I attacked... attacked a city to the west of Camelot. My advisors had told me a few weeks prior that the town was sympathetic to the demons and they suspected multiple Emperors were being harbored there in secret. Blind with rage, I used the full power of Excalibur and annihilated the entire area. I destroyed everything. Everyone. I smashed buildings to pieces. Cut women and children apart like I was a butcher. Slaughtered fathers and brothers, mothers and daughters. I unleashed my divine magic, thinking I was seeing demonic possession in the eyes of everyone around me. By the time I had finished, three hundred thousand were eradicated from the face of the Earth."

Arthur chuckled bitterly. "And that wasn't even the worst part. It turned out the demons had deceived me. Those intelligence reports were planted by a bad actor. The city was fiercely loyal to my cause. The demons had tricked me into killing my own subjects!"

Blake's expression fell. He had never heard this part of history before, and he imagined in his head how horrified and devastated he would have felt if he had done such a thing himself.

"How could I go on after what I had done?" Arthur asked, his question wistful and without answers. "So I sought my own destruction. I looked for a certain individual who I knew would be powerful enough to kill me, but would not be a demon. To say there weren't many of them that existed would be an understatement."

Arthur lifted his head and met Blake's gaze. His grim smile hurt to look at.

"That person was... your mother. Amelia Greyheart. More specifically, the original Amelia. Your mother's true name was Annette, and her 'Amelia' identity was implanted by your father at her request. Anyway. I fought her for a long time, and the Black Witch eventually killed me. I asked her to devour me, take over my essence, and turn me into a weapon against the demons. But... haha. She defied my request, even in death."

"The next thing I knew, I woke up inside Excalibur, and fifteen years had passed." Arthur said, his tone mirthless. "I only learned some years ago that Amelia Greyheart had devoured my body, but not my soul. She deliberately let me go. That much I'm confident of."

"I never knew any of this." Blake said quietly.

"I don't talk about the past much." Arthur replied. He shrugged. "There's no point. It all happened 100,000 years ago. These days, I just seek to impart what little meaningless words of 'wisdom' I can to the new generations. Not that there's much of that to go around. A sinner like me is better off keeping his mouth shut."

Arthur chuckled. "The other Heroes hate your father for what he did to Solomon and Jeremiah. But what do you think, Blake? Do you think his sin is worse than mine? What's worse? Depriving humanity of two dead ghosts, or exterminating hundreds of thousands of living, breathing brothers and sisters? I think the answer is clear."

"They're both bad." Blake said, his tone firmer than even he expected. "Taking a life is bad, no matter what. I believe that sometimes it's necessary. I would never rejoice over doing such a thing. Taking pleasure in death is the real sin. If you feel regret, if you vow never to do it again, and if you work to uplift others in the future, I believe you can redeem yourself."

"Redeem myself?" Arthur questioned. "What value is there in that? I don't deserve redemption. No amount of good I do will ever bring those innocents back."

Blake frowned. He sat up a little straighter. "You're right, Arthur. You can't bring them back. What you did, and what my father did, were objectively acts of evil. Whether you were deceived, or whether you wanted to kill that city full of people probably seems irrelevant, because they still ended up dead."

Blake continued. "But intent does matter. Dad told me that back on Ancient Earth, they had 'courts' that punished people based on their intent. Accidentally killing someone isn't the same thing as killing someone in a fit of rage, and that isn't the same as

premeditated murder. So even if 'dead is dead' is true, the circumstances leading up to the deaths matter."

"And here's the most important thing." Blake concluded. "As long as you're alive, or, well, half alive I suppose, you can change who you are and perform positive actions. Saving 300,000 lives won't undo the lives you ended, and neither will saving a million or a billion lives. But that doesn't mean it doesn't matter! Redemption isn't necessarily about absolving you of your past sins. It's about taking something bad and using it to do good. Just look at Beelzebub! If you think you're a sinner, then what is he?! That bastard killed a million humans, and now he's on our side, doing everything he can to right his past wrongs."

Blake leaned forward. "Are you going to honestly tell me you're a worse sinner than *Beelzebub*?"

Arthur listened to Blake's words. He stared off into the distance for a long while, thinking and mulling over what the kid had said.

"When did you... become so smart?" Arthur eventually asked.

"I'm not smart at all." Blake retorted, leaning back again. "I just think everyone deserves a second chance. That's why I want those Volgrim to go free. That's why I want you and Beelzebub to forgive yourselves. And my dad... if he were here."

The young man's expression became solemn. Arthur sensed the depression in Blake's eyes, but he didn't know how to alleviate his pain.

"...Arthur?" Blake said, his voice quiet. "Is my dad... really gone? He was a Hero, right? Couldn't he revive inside an artifact like you and the other Heroes?"

"Under normal circumstances, I would say yes." Arthur answered. "But... the Lazarus Tower retrieved human souls, and when it was destroyed, your father's soul would have been destroyed as well."

"But that's not right!" Blake exclaimed. "Uncle Jason would have ended up inside the tower too, but he revived despite the tower's destruction!"

"Jason's circumstances were... different." Arthur said, his tone gentle. "It was the Phoenix that brought him back because of her link to him. Your father had no such link."

"Dad once told me that Heroes could revive inside artifacts." Blake doggedly repeated. "Right? So, wouldn't my dad's artifact have a higher... priority? A higher priority than the

Tower? Or maybe if the Tower was blown up, he would go to his artifact afterward instead of the Great Beyond?"

"That might be true if your father had an artifact specially designed for him, such as by Archangel Camael." Arthur said. "Did he?"

"...No." Blake replied, his voice becoming quiet. He lowered his gaze, and tears welled up in his eyes. "But... but I thought... Heroes always attached themselves to their most treasured..."

"Heroes can attach themselves to any object when they die, even something as mundane as a spoon." Arthur said. "But the Tower has a stronger 'attraction force' than a mundane item like that. It would have to be a truly special artifact to have a greater pull than the tower. And besides... if your father had revived, we would have known by now. Think of how much time has passed."

Blake felt worse and worse every second. The more they continued on this line of dialogue, the more he wished he hadn't brought it up. The situation was truly unfixable.

"Dad was so *powerful* though." Blake mumbled, completely disheartened. "It's only been a few days in Realspace. Just because years have passed inside the Hall, that doesn't mean anything!"

"The revival times for Heroes do vary." Arthur admitted. "Stronger Heroes take longer to revive. Weaker ones often revive immediately within an artifact. If a strong Hero expends much of their energy before dying, or if they die in a manner most brutal, the time needed to revive can be lengthened greatly."

"It took you fifteen years to revive." Blake pointed out. "My dad was a pretty powerful Hero, right? And he fought a huge battle with Uncle Jason. So... isn't it possible he could...?"

Arthur sighed. He didn't want to disappoint the young man, but neither did he want to stomp on his feelings.

"It's... possible." Arthur reluctantly said. "But it's a far shot at best. It would only be possible if your father had deliberately or accidentally tied his Existence to a powerful enough artifact that it would have overridden the Tower's soul-saving function."

Arthur looked at Blake meaningfully. "Think carefully. Did your father have anything like that? An item he treasured deeply?"

Blake fell silent. He thought for a long time, but eventually...

"...Excalibur?" Blake asked. "He carried it around a lot."

"Excalibur is *my* artifact. I still reside within it." Arthur said pointedly. "Heroes who die cannot end up inside the artifact of another Hero."

"Wait!" Blake exclaimed. "What about Solomon's Crown? I mean, since Solomon died, it's available right? And, um... my father... well, he did wear it a lot. Plus, Solomon was..."

Blake trailed off. He didn't want to say it out loud, but in his heart, he wondered if devouring Solomon might have attached his father to the Crown.

"That possibility is... unlikely." Arthur said, shaking his head. "Even if a Hero's remnant soul perishes from an artifact, other Heroes have never ended up inside one."

"But you don't know that for sure." Blake pointed out. "Just because it hasn't happened in the past doesn't mean it can't happen in the future!"

Arthur shook his head. At this point, the boy was grasping for straws. There was no way to get through to him with logic.

"I am truly sorry, Blake." Arthur said. "Your father and your mother... it is not something any child should have to endure. I wish every day that they would come back for your sake, but increasingly..."

Blake's shoulders slumped in defeat. His expression became haggard. "I just don't get it. My dad was one thing, but my mom too? Why her? We don't even know what happened. She was here, and then she... wasn't. It's like she just disappeared into thin air. Did a secret assassin sneak into the Hall of Heroes? If so, why target her? Why *her*?? If she teleported out, why wasn't there a record? Like, just... why?!"

"I wish I had the answers." Arthur said. The Hero-King got up and walked over, taking a seat beside Blake. He wrapped his arm around Blake's back and squeezed his far shoulder to try and comfort him. "This universe is a terrible one. Awful things happen every day. Murder, rape, torture, you name it. Our enemies are everywhere, always looking to do harm unto us. And then, sometimes, it isn't even an enemy that brings forth pain, but the random chaos of the universe itself. A 'random act of god', they call it. As if God were the sort to do such a thing. I don't know. Maybe he is."

"I'm sure Moses and Aaron would have choice words if they heard you saying such blasphemy." Blake muttered, barely managing a joke. He tried to lighten the mood, but

his heart was as heavy as an anvil. "I'm sorry I'm such a downer, Arthur. I wish I could be strong like Levi."

"You are strong." Arthur reassured him. "You have a kind heart, but also a decisive one. Few young men your age could elucidate their philosophies so convincingly. You know, Jason wanted to bring about peace and forgiveness too, but he was much softer than you. Too soft. That's why his actions kept backfiring. He lacked a spine. He didn't draw lines in the sand, and his enemies walked all over him. You, on the other hand, clearly want to give the Volgrim a second chance, but *only* a second chance. Jason would never have stipulated that failing him a second time would result in their extermination, because he lacked the conviction you possess now. In my eyes, you're already a fine Hero compared to the Wordsmith in his youth."

"Uncle Jason did change his views later on." Blake pointed out.

"Certainly, but by then, it was too late." Arthur gently retorted. "The damage had already been done. Lives were lost that could never be recovered."

That gave Blake something to think about. He thoughtfully looked off into the distance, where he saw some birds frolicking in a pond, splashing water on their wings to clean themselves.

Blake was still young. 21 years old technically made him an adult, but he was uncertain about who he was, who he wanted to be, and what he could achieve. That uncertainty held him back and made him cautious, fearing that he might make a mistake that could hurt other people.

He was young, but he also possessed metaphysical powers that made him feel as if a great responsibility hung upon his shoulders.

"Hey, Arthur?" Blake said.

"What is it?" Arthur asked.

Blake paused.

"I want... to go back to Realspace. I want to help people out. I feel like I've trained enough with my powers, and I want to use them to do good. Do you think that would be okay?"

Arthur chuckled. "You're a man now. You don't need my permission. When I was your age, I had already ascended to the throne of Camelot five years earlier. As far as I'm

concerned, you are plenty ready to be making your own decisions. Just talk to Levi and let him know what you're planning to do."

Blake smiled sheepishly. "Yeah... that's a good point. I'll do that then."

"But," Arthur interjected, "while you may think you've mastered your powers, I believe you still have a lot to learn. It's been a few months since we trained together. What do you say about joining me in the Queenie? I have a new technique I'd like to teach you."

"Sure thing!" Blake said, cheering up noticeably. "I'm gonna go eat first. Let's meet there in an hour?"

"I'll be waiting." Arthur vowed.

Blake got up from the rock, then strolled out of the central park toward the food hall. As he walked, he thought about what Arthur had told him.

"You know what?" Blake said to himself. "I should put on Solomon's Crown. I want to learn more. I don't have to head to Realspace just yet. I bet if I do some practicing while wearing the Crown, I'll be able to expand my mind. Maybe I can finally increase my Mind's Eye and create more realistic projections. I might also be able to make myself smart enough I can properly hold a conversation with Psymin. That would be fun!"

Blake sometimes talked to himself. That's just how he was. Talking to himself out loud wasn't intentional, and he often cringed when he realized he'd just spoken in front of someone else. They always gave him a weird look, and it made him want to crawl into a hole and die.

"Oh well. Everyone has their quirks." Blake muttered.

As Blake headed down one of the Hall of Heroes' many brightly lit corridors, he suddenly flinched and paused mid-step, then took a step backward.

"Who's there?" Blake asked.

For the briefest of instants, he thought he saw a shadowy figure hiding in the hallway up ahead. But, like a trick of the light, it vanished, unseen.

"Hello?" Blake asked. "Is anyone there?"

He narrowed his eyes. Reaching out with his powers, he sensed the area around him. He didn't detect anything... or *anyone*. But that only made him more suspicious.

Blake started walking again. He rounded the corner, but he didn't see any other shadows sneaking in the distance up ahead.

"Must be seeing things..." Blake said, his eye twitching.

Part 722: Vulpanix's Will

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Volgarius.

To an outside observer, Volgarius might seem as if it had not changed much. Certainly, Mephisto had wreaked havoc, but 99% of the surface area was perfectly intact. Even if tens of billions of Volgrim had died, it was a tiny fraction of the population.

But the truth was, the loss of 95% of all Psions, including 99.99% of the military-level Psions, meant the Volgrim had been dealt a crippling blow. Psions were more than mere grunts to be disposed of in endless wars. They were efficient in all manner of construction-related tasks. They were researchers who studied worlds non-Psions could not traverse without special suits, armor, or vehicles. They were philosophers who pondered Truths of the universe. They were also spies who could infiltrate countless other lesser species, and who could keep an eye on the galaxy at large.

They even served as early warning systems in the event of hostile incursions from other galaxies...

Thus, the deaths of hundreds of trillions of Psions was a loss beyond belief. In order to create a single 9th Level Psion, one who ultimately killed herself, 99.9999% of all the energy each Psion could harness had evaporated into the nether.

Mephisto's onslaught had ultimately collapsed more than 74,000 stratoscrapers. What would have taken a few hundred 6th Level Psions to stop, or perhaps a handful of 7th Level Psions, had instead taken hundreds of thousands of 3rd and 4th Level Psions to prevent a runaway collapse of the entire stratoscraper network. These Psions, powerful compared to Demon Dukes and Emperors, were simply too weak to hold up and reinforce even a single stratoscraper by themselves. Each one weighed a billion tons and towered miles into the sky. They were named stratoscrapers explicitly because they 'scraped' Volgarius's lower atmosphere!

Across the entire Volgrim Empire, there were fewer than ten 'elite' Psions in the 7th Level who remained among the living. All of them, except for one, had been located off-world when Demila slaughtered the worlds of Naandril I, Naandril II, and Naandril III. That single elite Psion was Confessor Vulpanix.

Thanks to her intervention, the crisis had barely been stabilized, and the further collapse of stratoscrapers had finally ended. But her body was still not fully recovered from when Hope Hiro had killed her. She was quite weak, and possessed nowhere close to the strength a full-power 7th Level Psion should.

It was now, 21 galactic days after the Wordsmith's apparent death, that she finally found time to rest. Her emotions turbulent, Confessor Vulpanix took a shuttle to one of the many nearly-empty Psionic Enclaves scattered across Volgarius. Using a shuttle was, in and of itself, something shameful. Psions never rode on board spaceships unless it was part of a specific job or a combined-species ship where their specific talents were needed, such as surveillance ships meant to study mud-dweller worlds. Her body was so weak and wracked with fatigue that she simply could not levitate or fly at a reasonable speed to traverse Volgarius's airspace.

Thus, she didn't.

When she entered the Enclave, she was struck yet again with a dull, pulsating sense of grief. There were still millions of Psion bodies that lay dead inside the Enclave. It was impossible to quickly clean up trillions of corpses across all the Volgrim-controlled worlds, especially when the Technopaths were stretched thin still trying to rescue survivors trapped inside the rubble of the collapsed stratoscrapers.

Vulpanix looked left, and she looked right. No matter what rooms she scanned, there were bodies laying on the floors, fallen onto tables, or slumped in chairs. Demila's attack had been so quick and brutal that many Psions had no time to react before their lives were extinguished. In the history of the Volgrim Empire, those who could sneak attack a Psion and kill them in an instant were barely countable on one hand, yet Demila had done so on a scale that boggled the imagination.

Vulpanix staggered over to the only empty room she could find; a conference room that apparently had no business happening at the time the Psions had died. She sat inside a chair and collapsed forward onto the table, her mind and soul tired beyond description. Her eyes closed, and she felt fatigue swallowing her mind.

In all Vulpanix's cycles, never had she felt as drained as she did now. Her body twitched with electric pain. She felt similar to a human who had been forced to run a marathon for three weeks straight with barely any water or food, and no rest.

Every muscle hurt. Every thought was pain. Even opening her eyelids was taxing.

The only reason she had made it this far was the stubborn belief that no lesser Psions should see her struggling. It was a form of ego etched into her bones.

Vulpanix chuckled mirthlessly. She remembered that it had actually been Demila who chastised her, when she awoke after her First Death, for looking weak and frail in front of others.

Demila.

The villain herself.

[Did you know...? I always... loathed you.] Vulpanix thought, her words projecting outward to no-one in particular. [I wish... I had been the one... to kill you. You ruined everything. Your greed... pathetic. Worse than a... mud-dweller.]

Emotions struggled to express themselves within Vulpanix's heart. Psions were hardy creatures. Their entire species' structure raised and bred them to be practically immune to emotions. They never felt sad. They never felt depressed. They rarely expressed anger or happiness. Emotions ran contrary to everything their lofty existences stood for. It was only when they were young, immature, and inexperienced that a scant few expressed any sort of strong emotions. In order to progress their Seeds, they always learned to strip those feelings away.

But now, all alone, inside an Enclave with nobody around who could see her...

...Vulpanix wept.

Her chest silently heaved. The formerly proud, lofty Psion was stricken with a sense of crisis. Never had she felt so alone, so frail, and so pathetic as at that moment. The knowledge that former comrades she once admired, former leaders she looked up to and envied, former warriors she hungered to surpass... were all dead? It destroyed her.

She was the strongest Psion alive now. Not because she had earned it, but merely *by default*. Merely because there were no others still alive she could compare herself to in the hopes of surpassing them someday.

Furthermore, she was far, far from the strongest that had ever lived. Among the 7th Level Psions, she was indeed considered the mightiest of her generation. But she was a spring chicken compared to the Executors, and a grain of sand compared to the Second Founder.

The Second Founder...

Vulpanix choked down a sob. She tried to rein in her emotions, but she was so broken-hearted that doing so was now one of the hardest things she had ever done. In that moment, she didn't even have the strength to lift an arm and wipe away her tears. She simply laid her head on the table and wept.

* * *

An hour passed. Vulpanix sobbed as much as she needed to. She rebuilt her mental barriers and chastised herself for her moment of weakness. But ultimately, she excused her actions due to the extenuating circumstances. During times like these, she thought it was okay so long as nobody witnessed her pitiful display.

Eventually, she sat up in the chair and focused her mind. She closed her eyes and began to meditate.

The world became silent.

She focused on regaining her vital energy. She used her exhaustion as a way of breaking past her previous limits.

Psions were not like other Sentients. They cultivated diligently, pursuing the dao of their predecessors, seeking Truths, and learning to use their powers to push past the limits placed upon them by the universe.

Thus, when a Psion had completely exerted themselves, that was when they were most capable of breaking past their limits.

With her body, mind, soul, and Psionic Seed exhausted, cracks were showing across Vulpanix's being.

But her eyes shone with determination!!

[I see now. The path before me is finally clear!]

Wild fluctuations of energy began to circulate around Vulpanix. Her Psionic Seed trembled violently, the cracks on its surface becoming especially pronounced as she began to enter a higher state of being.

The energy inside her body thickened. Her skin began to glow. Slowly, a phantasmal, illusory figure began to appear.

[Child... child... so young... so young...]

Vulpanix's eyelids pressed down against her face. Her forehead creased as the pressure of an Ancient Psion, formidable beyond belief, spoke to her from the Psionic Well.

[Ancestor.] Vulpanix said, stretching out with her senses.

The world around her faded away, and she found herself standing inside an ancient temple, one that was illuminated with torches, shadows flickering all around the hall.

Vulpanix was now seated atop a throne in the center of the temple. When she opened her eyes, she saw before her a female Psion wearing rags that barely covered her body. Her skin was colored green. She was covered in blackened bruises. Scars lined her skin, and she looked so frail and gaunt that it seemed as if a stiff breeze would knock her over.

But her body... radiated the divine power of a 9th Level Psion!

She was a Supremator, like Founder Dosena!

Her weakness was not a facade. She was so powerful that she could kill Vulpanix with a flick of her finger, but at this moment, she was clearly at death's door.

Vulpanix's eyes widened. She noticed the throne she was sitting upon, and hurriedly stood up, feeling too ashamed to be sitting in such a lofty position. She jumped away from it as if it were poisonous, then dropped to one knee and bowed her head reverentially toward the haggard figure before her.

[Supremator Lanuris.] Vulpanix said, quickly addressing the superior Psion she had immediately recognized. [Many times I have gazed upon your image, wishing I could meet you. This is... an honor. Words fail me.]

[Rise, child.] Supremator Lanuris said, waving her hand to lift Vulpanix to her feet. [I am nothing now. A shadow... of myself. Do not revere me. Do not envy me.]

Vulpanix's heart surged with emotion. Despite the sad image of a fallen Supremator standing before her, Vulpanix felt nothing but admiration and awe. Any Psion would. They all longed to rise to such lofty heights someday, even if the likelihood were essentially nonexistent.

[My child.] Lanuris said slowly. [You have witnessed many distressing things. I see through your worries. You fear that the end of the Volgrim Empire is nigh. You doubt your ability to protect its people.]

Vulpanix's eyes became slightly moist as she struggled to hold back tears again. [I am ashamed. My weakness is apparent at a glance.]

[Long has it been since I spoke to an Inheritor.] Lanuris replied, her eyes blinking ever so deliberately. [I have considered few worthy. The last one I spoke to was the one named…]

She fell silent for a long moment, then looked away, struggling to remember a name.

[…Nufaris. Yes. I remember now. I sensed in him the same potential I sense in you. A determination to surpass everyone else. A belief in his abilities that transcended common sense.]

The ancient Psion casually waved her hand in an outward arc. [Dispel any reverence you may have toward me. I am not worth admiring, child. Compared to you, I am truly nothing at all.]

[How can you say such words, Supremator?] Vulpanix asked in disbelief. [If it were not for the efforts of ancient ones such as yourself, our species would have fallen to the Sentinels. I am honored to be in your presence.]

A long minute followed. Lanuris gazed at Vulpanix with eyes that seemed to pierce the fabric of reality.

[So.] Lanuris said softly, lowering her eyes. [That is the history She teaches you. It is a kindness the likes of us do not deserve.]

Vulpanix blinked. She cocked her head. [Supremator?]

[What remains of me is little more than a minute, fragmented soul.] Lanuris said, her tone halting and pained. [The era I lived in was a bloody one, marked by Psion infighting. We were a brutal species. We killed, and killed, and killed some more. Everything we did was for our own selfish benefit. Among my fellow Supremators, I was among the worst of them.]

She shook her head.

[You have not been taught the Truths of those ancient times. Perhaps that is for the best. Since you have appeared before me, it is likely due to Her will. She wishes for me to bestow a Comprehension upon you, one that will allow you to become a pillar of our species.]

Vulpanix's expression flickered. [Are you referring to… the Second Founder?]

[Indeed. Supremator Dosena is the greatest Psion who has ever lived.] Lanuris answered, but her tone was notably bitter and slightly tinged with resentment and awe.

[Even though she killed me, I could not utter a word of complaint. She had the right to do so. I lived and died by the philosophy she weaponized against me... as did all the other Supremators.]

By now, Vulpanix's look of awe had visibly faded. She was growing more confused by the minute.

[Supremator Lanuris, are you saying that Founder Dosena controls the Psionic Well?]

[Of course.] Lanuris answered without hesitation. [She chooses who rises and who falls. She judges all Psions. Did you believe that the Psionic Well had existed since time immemorial? Silly child. It was Founder Dosena who created the Well, in order to create a new paradigm for all future Psions to follow.]

Vulpanix's pupils shrunk to pinpricks. This was something she had never heard in all her cycles alive! She was shocked beyond comprehension! Beyond belief!

[She... created the Well?! She killed the other Supremators? What- why? How?!]

[That is not for me to say.] Lanuris answered quietly. [Since she has chosen for you to speak to me in this time of the Empire's greatest need, she has also chosen to inform you of its greatest secrets. After we are done, you must go to see her, child.]

The Supremator blinked her eyes heavily. She seemed more tired than when she had first appeared.

[My child. I am truly proud to see what the Psions have become under Dosena. Unfortunately, the mass-casualty event brought about by the greed of Creator Demila is beyond description. It is entirely possible that the Second Founder has lost faith in herself. In my heyday, she was the Psion I looked up to and feared the most. Her willpower was so terrifying that nothing could stop her. Not even the machinations of enemies too strong for her to ever defeat. Not even the limitations of her own biology...]

Lanuris sighed.

[Dosena believed that the Psions would become stronger if they ceased their constant infighting. Our unending conflict was not something a child like you could fathom. Entire worlds were left scorched in the wake of our civil wars. During the eon since the ending of the Great Wars, it has been my pleasure to witness the complete cessation of inter-Psion conflicts. But, looking back, I do now wonder if Dosena's forceful alteration of the natural order was perhaps... *overzealous*.]

After a moment, Lanuris shook her head. [Never mind the ramblings of a long-dead relic. It is not my place to judge the Second Founder. Even if she erred, her intentions were noble, and her character upright. More importantly, this is *your* ascension. I am running out of time to bequeath you the Comprehension you have rightfully earned.]

Vulpanix straightened her posture. She listened intently as Lanuris waved her wand and began to conjure a projection of energy before herself.

[You are a Temporal Manipulator. I am not. My Comprehensions in Temporal Mechanics are minimal at best. But when I was still alive, I was considered the foremost authority on Biological Manipulation.]

[Biological Manipulation?] Vulpanix asked.

[I am not surprised you have not heard of it.] Lanuris answered mildly. [I pioneered this branch of Psionics myself, but it has gone extinct over the last eon. In fact, most Supremators pioneered a branch of Psionics. But never mind that. Biological Manipulation focuses on constructing and deconstructing biological entities at the cellular level. It is a highly technical branch of Psionics that very few are adept enough to master. One must already possess a high level of Brain Enhancing to even begin; a criteria which you luckily fulfill.]

She continued. [My discipline of Psionics is the bane of Body Enhancers. Biological Manipulation allows one to tear through even the most fortified bodies known to Volgrim by uncovering the tiniest biological weaknesses and striking them with one's full force. At the same time, if you master it to a level comparable to myself, you will gain the ability to strengthen and mutate your form through focused intent.]

[Mutate my form?] Vulpanix pressed. [Why would I do such a thing?]

Lanuris smirked. [Child, look upon my visage. Do I seem weak and frail to you? My appearance is a deception. When I was alive, my body was stronger than any Body Enhancer, even the mightiest ones you no doubt have read about in the historical ledgers. Body Enhancing is a simple and brutish way of simply empowering one's cells with raw psionic energy to enhance their physical power. But Biological Manipulation? It is a curated and focused effort to carefully enhance every facet of one's being.]

Suddenly, Lanuris moved. She rushed at Vulpanix, startling her when four arms erupted from Lanuris's back. Lanuris grabbed Vulpanix and smashed her into the ground,

dragging her backward before lifting her up and slamming her back into a sitting position on the golden throne.

Vulpanix's eyes trembled with shock. This was merely the faintest wisp of Lanuris's ancient soul, but she still wielded such frightening power!

Just as quickly as Lanuris attacked, she released her grip on Vulpanix and let her go. Lanuris retracted her arms, and they seamlessly melted into her back as if they had never existed.

[Biological Manipulation is a powerful combat art. But more than that, it is a science and a discipline. If you are willing to learn, I will impart my Comprehensions upon you. But it will be up to you to progress past the minimum of my teachings.]

Vulpanix's heart beat faster after witnessing the striking power of her superior. She climbed out of the throne and dropped to one knee.

[Supremator. I am honored by your acknowledgment. I will do everything in my power to revive your ancient Psionic discipline. Please teach me...]

[Very well. Listen carefully, for my time here is limited.] Lanuris said sagely, her eyes glowing as she began to recite her Mantra.

* * *

* * *

An unknown amount of time passed. Vulpanix sat cross-legged in front of her new mentor, listening intently as Lanuris's voice began to grow fainter and fainter.

[Thus, it is only by focusing your mind that you will be able to look deeper and deeper into the gaps between atoms.] Lanuris said. Her voice was now growing so weak that it seemed she was on her last legs. [Alas. Our time has ended. This is all the knowledge I can pass on to you, child.]

[I offer my thanks, ancestor.] Vulpanix said, bowing her head respectfully. [I will contemplate your words until I have fully comprehended them.]

[You may be the last chance for our Empire to prevail, child.] Lanuris said, her eyelids growing heavy. [Once you have solidified your Seed, go to Dosena. She is waiting... for you. It is time... for you... to learn the Truths you must know... to support our people.]

Her body turned hazy. Then, like smoke in the wind, it vanished.

Vulpanix lifted her head. She stared at the spot where her ancestor had been sitting, then sighed.

[I will remember your words. Always.]

Moments later, her body erupted with power. Vulpanix roared to the heavens as her Psionic Seed exploded with violent force, then shattered and reformed!

A surge of energy shook Volgarius. All around the planet, countless lower Psions whirled to look in her direction. They gasped as they sensed the ascension of a new Executor.

[The Founders guide us! The Founders protect us! We have not been abandoned! All hail Executor Vulpanix!]

Vulpanis's eyes turned golden as she stood up within the Enclave. Her weakness was gone. Her body had healed, and she had fully acclimated her True Soul with its vessel.

Vulpanix stood up. She levitated into the air, then flickered upward, arriving in the stratosphere. Below her, countless lower Psions looked up with awe in their eyes. For the first time since Demila's rampage, they sensed the power of a High Psion protecting them from above.

[Hear me!] Vulpanis shouted, her voice projecting across the entire world of Volgarius. [I am Vulpanix! I am the only living Executor of our species! But I will NOT be the last! More will arise! Whether it takes ten cycles or ten million, more will Ascend! Our species will not go out with a whimper! We will stand tall and fight back against our dark fate!]

A surge of rage rushed through Vulpanix's veins. She shakily pointed a finger up to the sky.

[Do you hear me, Archangels?! DO YOU HEAR ME?! So long as I live, I will never bow to you! I will never admit defeat! I will fight even when the battle has ended! Even if my body is brought to ruin, the last scraps of my consciousness will defy you until nothing is left of me!]

[This is my will! This is my Seed! I promise to bring your machinations to ruin, foul usurpers!!]

All across Volgarius, Psions, Technopaths, and Changelings lifted their heads and cheered. They could not help it. Their hearts had fallen to the pits, and even if she was 'only' an Executor, she represented the faintest light of hope for their species.

Humans could cling to hope, and so too could the Volgrim.

Inside the Founder's Thumb, Unarin sighed. Then he chuckled.

"Well, *that's* going to make diplomacy a little harder. But then again, I suppose if my job were too easy, it wouldn't be any fun..."

The First Founder took a long sip of wine as he contemplated his future options...

Part 723: Becoming a Founder

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Volgarius.

Vulpanix's ascension was a major event, and the first light of hope the Volgrim had seen in a long time. Ever since the Plague first appeared, they had slowly begun losing the war. They recently lost 95% of their Psions. A huge black scar tore across the homeworld. The demons were growing stronger, and the Dolgrimites had played a card that left the rest of the Volgrim reeling.

But now, they had a new Executor. Perhaps, due to the crisis that had swallowed the Volgrim, they might even obtain another one after Vulpanix.

That was a matter for the future. As Vulpanix reveled in her ascension, she allowed herself a moment of joy. She wasn't one for such trite emotions, but achieving the peak of Psionic power outside of a Supremator was a privilege only a precious few had enjoyed over the eons. Vulpanix had not yet reached a Chron of age (100,000 cycles), but she had become the last pillar of the Psions. Septillions would come to rely on her.

The weight of this new crown was heavy indeed...

As Vulpanix levitated in the lower atmosphere, she sensed the approach of a small shuttlecraft. When it approached, a messenger Technopath on board sent a message to her.

"The Founders congratulate you on your ascension. When you are ready, please pay the First Founder a visit."

Vulpanix slowly blinked all of her eyes. [I am ready now.]

An instant later, Vulpanix vanished. Her body stepped across space and she traveled a tenth of the way around the planet. She flickered two more times, ultimately arriving above the Founder's Fingers.

For a brief moment, her emotions dulled. She was still coming to terms with the realization of what she had done, along with her new responsibilities. She did not allow her emotions to cloud her judgment, and summarily flickered downward, arriving on the landing platform for the Founder's Thumb.

Inside, she found a familiar face. Muuxunuu stepped outside and blinked her limpid blue eyes at the newest Executor.

"Executor Vulpanix. I am pleased to witness your ascension. Founder Unarin is awaiting your arrival inside his sanctum."

[Many thanks, Administrator Muuxunuu.] Vulpanix replied.

Muuxunuu led Vulpanix inside the Founder's Thumb. Eventually, they stopped at the entrance to Unarin's Sanctum, and Vulpanix entered.

After Muuxunuu pulled the great doors shut behind Vulpanix, the newest Executor lifted her head to look up at Unarin, who was now sitting across from Dosena at a small table. Vulpanix flickered upward and arrived before the two of them with her head bowed.

[Founders.] Vulpanix said solemnly.

"Congratulations on your ascension." Unarin said, looking at her for a moment with a smile playing upon his face. He returned his gaze to the table, where a primitive board game had been laid out, and he and Dosena were silently playing together. "Take a seat, young Executor."

Vulpanix opened her eyes and nodded. She pulled out a seat and sat down. Only now did she carefully examine the First and Second Founders.

Unarin seemed no different than he always was. Supremely confident, unbothered, unworried about anything in particular.

But Dosena was different. She was visibly dispirited. Not a lick of Psionic Energy radiated from her body. She seemed weaker than the lowliest of Initiators. If her majesty and appearance was not well-known to all Volgrim, Vulpanix might have assumed Unarin had taken pity on an urchin and invited her inside.

Dosena glanced at Vulpanix and nodded. Then she reached out to the board and placed a piece on it.

Vulpanix examined the game between the Founders. She was unfamiliar with it, and in fact had never seen it before. It was shaped like a square, and had dozens of lines criss-crossing horizontally and vertically to create an interwoven grid of squares. There were small circular white and black pieces placed all across it, forming a pattern Vulpanix couldn't immediately deduce.

"This is the game of Go." Unarin casually volunteered. "I've been looking through a lot of ancient record from the human's homeworld, Earth. The humans have an interesting saying... keep your friends close, and your enemies closer. Due to recent Truths revealed, I am growing uncertain of what exactly our relationship is evolving into."

Unarin looked up at Vulpanix. "What do you think, Executor? Are the humans our friends, or are they our enemies?"

Vulpanix did not immediately answer. It didn't take a genius to determine that Unarin was testing her. Any answer flippantly given would reveal something about her, so she was in no rush to speak.

Unarin returned his gaze to the board, and the table fell silent. For five long minutes, Vulpanix mulled the answer over.

[The humans are neither.] Vulpanix eventually replied. [They are a necessary evil we must endure. But if we look back at the ancient history, I believe that humanity could have become our closest allies or our worst enemies. The result merely depended on how we treated them.]

Unarin nodded, raising his eyebrows with a faint smile. "A good answer. Not perfect, but one that reveals wisdom beyond your years. You're right, Vulpanix. The humans could have become our greatest allies, had we only treated them better. Alas, we did not. And now, here we are, the Truth behind the Plague having finally reared its ugly head."

The First Founder chuckled. He seemed to find this new Plague business mentally stimulating to the point he seemed a madman. The walls were closing in around the Volgrim Empire, yet its First Founder was seemingly unbothered.

After a moment of silence, Unarin faintly bobbed his head in Dosena's direction. "Oh, by the way, please forgive the Second Founder. She has lost the ability to speak. Her Psionics have been completely sealed. If you wish to speak with her, you will have to interface directly with her mind."

Vulpanix's eyes widened. She looked at Dosena with shock. [I-interface directly? That is a breach of decorum I cannot possibly...]

She metaphorically swallowed her words when the Second Founder directed an apathetic look her way. It seemed Dosena did not care much for such matters.

Vulpanix bowed her head slightly. [I... understand. If that is your will, Second Founder.]

She hesitated a few moments longer. Touching directly on another Psion's mind and reading their thoughts was extremely offensive, and considered a slap across the face. Demila had done so to Vulpanix, and she still remembered the shame and helplessness she had felt when it happened. Then again, looking back, it seemed Demila's disgusting personality had revealed many warning signs her brothers and sisters had overlooked.

Eventually, Vulpanix relented. She hesitantly sent the weakest possible wisp of telepathic energy toward the Second Founder's mind, only for her link to crash against a damn-near impenetrable barrier she had not anticipated. Even though Dosena no longer wielded her Psionic power, her brain was still a fortress that no weak or casual telepathic strike could penetrate.

Vulpanix was not disappointed by this revelation. Instead, she was greatly relieved. She realized this indicated that Dosena had not fallen below the rank of Initiator, but simply had lost her Psionics for a while. How long that period of time entailed was anybody's guess, but eventually, Dosena would regain her strength.

Vulpanix narrowed her eyes. She increased the strength of her telepathic link, but even that fell far short of what she needed. She grunted and intensified her psionic link more, and more, and even more.

Despite being an Executor, she was having to put 75% of her full strength into establishing a mental link between herself and the Second Founder. All of this happened over the course of a mere thirty seconds while Unarin faintly smiled, understanding what was going on, and Dosena simply stared at the Go board, seemingly not even able to sense Vulpanix's telepathic intrusions.

Sweat began to drip down Vulpanix's face. Sweat! She couldn't believe that a powerless Psion had such resilient mental defenses. She readied herself to gather up every drop of her power to attempt one final push...

But at that moment, Unarin spoke up. "Alright, alright. You've made your point. Let her in."

Vulpanix glanced at Unarin. He was looking across the table at Dosena, who simply rolled her eyes.

All at once, the barrier blocking Vulpanix's mental intrusion vanished. She managed to penetrate into Dosena's mind, but even then, she was only able to touch upon the surface layer. She could only see the thoughts her superior wanted her to see.

[Your telepathic skill is an embarrassment to all Executors.] Dosena said, her tone mild. She could not project her words outward, but she was able to speak to Vulpanix now that she allowed her junior to read her surface thoughts. [In the future, you will work on improving this skill. It is a core ability for those who wish to ascend to Supremator, in addition to Primal Psionics.]

Vulpanix blinked. [Supremator? You believe I have the capability?]

Dosena snorted and tapped a finger on the Go board seemingly at random. [All Psions do. In the past, I prevented many from reaching my level. That was a deliberate choice. But after recent events, it seems I must relax those limitations greatly. This is not a decision I am pleased about, but it is a necessary evil.]

Unarin nodded. "A necessary evil, indeed."

Vulpanix started to say something else, but then she paused to look at the First Founder. [You... heard the Second Founder's words? But how? She is not able to project her thoughts outward.]

A tiny smirk appeared at the corner of Unarin's mouth. "Oh, Dosena and I have our own way of communicating. Pay it no mind. Continue with your conversation, as before."

Vulpanix remained suspicious, but matters between the Founders were not her business unless they directly informed her otherwise. Thus, she returned her attention to the Second Founder.

[Second Founder. When I Ascended, I spoke to Supremator Lanuris inside the Psionic Well.] Vulpanix said. [She told me our meeting was your doing.]

Dosena slowly blinked her eyes. She directed a measured gaze Vulpanix's way.

[It was.]

Vulpanix didn't know how to react to Dosena's simple admission. Her entire life, she and all other Psions had believed the Psionic Well was an independent entity, something that was governed by its own rules. For it to actually be controlled directly by the Second Founder was unthinkable. Such a possibility seemed so outrageous, she couldn't bring herself to believe it.

[Why did you want me to meet her?] Vulpanix asked quietly.

[Because you are our last Champion.] Dosena answered. [I am unable to wield any of my Psionic powers. The Empire no longer has a protector. A new one must arise. That new one is you.]

A moment of silence followed. Dosena lifted her chin to look down the bridge of her nose at her younger companion.

[Vulpanix. I called you here today to assess you. I have been quietly testing you in a variety of ways, and have found your mental state to be... satisfactory. You have met my criteria for an elite-]

"Someone's feeling humble." Unarin joked, causing both women to glance at him. "You really ought to stop placing yourself on such a pedastel, Dosena. Your ego is ridiculous, even by my standards."

Dosena glared at him, then returned her attention to Vulpanix. [As I was *saying*, you have met my criteria for an elite. Despite your screw-up against the Second Wordsmith, you have proven to be an outstanding seed. In only 95,000 cycles, you have risen to the level of Executor. I believe with certain Truths revealed, you will be able to rise to the rank of Supremator in record time and become our Empire's newest protector.]

Vulpanix cocked her head. She returned to a previous thought she was going to speak before it had been interrupted. [I do not understand. Millions of cycles have passed since the Great Wars. Not once has an Executor managed to rise to the level of Supremator. Is it really true that you prevented their ascensions deliberately?]

Dosena looked at Vulpanix evenly.

[Yes. I did.]

Vulpanix almost felt as if the room had chilled by a few degrees. She shifted in her seat, uncertain how to respond.

She didn't have to. Dosena continued speaking after a moment. [I placed a limit upon the Psionic Well. Unless I wish it, no Executor can rise to the 9th Level. However, I also made it so I could release the seal at any point. If I ever needed, I could have uplifted the Executors immediately. This is something I informed every Executor of, and which they were forced to accept. All of them, without fail, accepted this Truth.]

All at once, Vulpanix felt enlightened. As a 7th Level Psion, she had not been privy to the secrets known by Executors. She had heard rumors for years, even grumblings from certain Executors, but never did they elucidate their concerns enough for her to understand.

Now that she had become one herself, she finally understood. The Executors had known about the Psionic Well's limitations, but they did not have the power to unseat Dosena. They were at her mercy. She decided who would rise and who would fall. Naturally, this had enraged some, perhaps even all of the Executors, but what could they do? Dosena had killed other Supremators in the past. She was far too strong for even the united power of all the Executors to overcome...

[Why did you hold back our people from ascending?] Vulpanix asked, her expression turning from surprise, to dismay, to anger. [If the Executors had been Supremators, they could have held back Demila and saved countless lives during Mephisto's rampage! If we had an army of Supremators, we could have pushed back the Plague, and maybe have even won this war before it began!]

Hardly had the words left her mind before Vulpanix realized the answer. [Wait... were you afraid? Afraid the other Executors would rise up and unseat you from power? Were you fearful that you would lose control over all the Psions? Is that what this was all about? Pride and ego when our civilization's fate was at stake?!]

For the first time, Vulpanix talked back to her superior. She did not hide her anger, because she could not. She would not be being true to her Seed if she withheld her criticism, and furthermore, Dosena deserved that criticism! Her selfishness caused the deaths of trillions of Volgrim!

Dosena kept her cool. She was not offended by Vulpanix's righteous anger, nor her inflammatory words.

[The Truths you know are too shallow, Vulpanix. That is why I brought you here. From your limited viewpoint, my actions may seem to have been borne of ego, but I believe that once you understand the full context of the ancient Truths, you will not feel the same way as you do now.]

[So you deny that what you did was done because of ego?] Vulpanix challenged. [I do not know what 'Truths' you think will change my mind, but I must say I am truly disappointed! What could you possibly tell me that would allow me to accept the damage

your decisions have caused?! Trillions have died! TRILLIONS! And if we start from the beginning of the Plague's arrival, SEPTILLIONS!]

Still, Dosena remained calm. [What if the Truths I intended to reveal would inform you of the ancient history our people have not even recorded in data crystals?]

Vulpanix paused. A spike of shock went through her heart.

[You mean to tell me… of the Great Wars?]

Unarin smirked. "Before the Great Wars. Before the Uprising. Even before… the Primordial Climb of our ancient ancestors."

The First Founder let his words percolate in the air for a moment.

"Long ago, before our people became the enlightened civilization you know today, we were a savage and barbaric race. We had many trappings of prestige, shiny structures to live within, and were slowly expanding across the galaxy. But in reality, we had been infested by a rot that went deeper than you could possibly imagine."

He continued. "What young ones like you, and even ones as old as Demila cannot possibly understand, is that the tribulations of the past informed the policy of today. We have maintained vague records of the ancient wars. We have kept our species informed regarding the broad strokes of those dark times. But we have deliberately gone out of our way to hide the most vile, shameful, and disgusting actions taken by our ancestors."

[Not because we were afraid the general populace would learn of these Truths,] Dosena said calmly, [but because knowing these Truths would almost certainly ignite small to medium-scale conflicts, weakening us when we needed to maintain strength in the face of our enemies.]

[But now it's too late.] Vulpanix said mildly. [We've all but lost this war.]

The two Founders looked at Vulpanix and shook their heads.

"The war is unending." Unarin said solemnly. "Whether we live or die, it will continue. Whether our Eternity ends and ten more pass, it will continue. Our goal is not to win the war, because the war cannot be won. We only intend to live according to our values and make known the name of the fearsome Volgrim. We will hold on as long as possible, and then, as with countless other civilizations before ours, we will vanish into the cosmic dust of history."

A smothering sensation enveloped Vulpanix's heart. She realized, in that moment, that she did not understand the goals of the Founders, and perhaps she never would. Their thoughts were so much loftier than hers that even when she tried to distill or dumb them down, she still overlooked all the nuances of their thoughts.

[If the war is not lost, but it also cannot be won, then what is the point of our struggle?] Vulpanix asked, feeling stupid for even speaking the words out loud. [Are we not struggling in vain?]

"What you're asking is truly a fundamental question of Life itself." Unarin answered. "What is Life? In my uneducated, simple-minded opinion, Life is the struggle of a species to rise up and dominate the other species around it. This can take the form of outbreeding other species, dominating them with military might, outcompeting them in science, and so on. But if I may, I must also posit that the point of Life, for the Volgrim, is to ascend above the other mud-dwelling rabble-rousers. We must become enlightened. We must not bully them. We must show strength, even if we are weak. We must be proud, but not arrogant. We must show respect to those worthy of our respect, but never contempt to anyone but the most contemptible."

Unarin waved his hand casually. "I'm rambling again. Never mind me. Let's get back to the main point of discussion. Dosena, would you like to enlighten her first, or should I?"

Dosena touched her chin. She looked up at the ceiling thoughtfully.

[I believe you should be the one to speak first, Unarin. My tale is most relevant after yours. Your words should prove to be the most enlightening, given you were the architect behind the downfall of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.]

The First Founder smiled.

"So be it then."

He reached over and touched a datapad. After a minute or two, the door to the Sanctum opened. Muuxunuu entered holding a small box. She walked up the steps to the second floor and handed the box to Unarin, bowed her head, and left. Unarin stared at her backside as he watched her depart.

"We lost so many valuable things in the ancient times." Unarin said wistfully. "So many people."

After Muuxunuu exited the Sanctum and shut the door, it took Unarin a few moments to collect himself. He opened up the small box to reveal a triangular datacore, along with three Remote Connection Nodes. He tossed one across the table, and Dosena caught it with a snap of her wrist. She took the tiny node and affixed it to the side of her head. Unarin did the same while handing the third one to Vulpanix.

"Put this on the same way Dosena and I have done. We will be using this device to share our knowledge of the ancient past with you, Vulpanix. From this point on, you will be considered a Founder-level figure in the Volgrim Empire. The secrets we are about to share must not be disclosed to anyone outside of the privileged few, no matter what. Are we clear?"

Vulpanix nodded and pressed the node to the side of her head.

[On my honor, I will not breathe a word of anything you are about to tell me to another figure.] She promised.

Unarin shrugged. "I wouldn't have brought you here if I didn't trust you. But it is good to hear confirmation directly."

He placed the triangular data core in the center of the table, then activated it, causing a blue light to emit from the core.

"Let us begin."

Part 724: The Ancient Volgrim Empire

Millions of cycles in the past, before the Great Wars, the Volgrim emerged from the primordial soup of their home world, Grimvolas, slowly evolving into four distinct subspecies.

The first to evolve were the Dolgrimites. They were the most primally attuned beasts who could devour other forms of life to empower themselves and evolve their bodies.

At a point unknown, the first Psions evolved from the Dolgrimites. The two species engaged in a brutal war of dominance that rapidly engulfed the world of Grimvolas.

Later, as time passed, the Technopaths evolved. They were the third sub-species to depart from the Dolgrimites, and they evolved as a result of certain high-minded ideals being passed down from the Dolgrimites who were most closely attuned to technology. Thus, these usurpers began to study the art of the metal gods, and were cast out by the Dolgrimites, branded heretics by their former brothers and sister, and left to found their own empire.

The last to evolve were the Changelings. They emerged just 20,000 cycles after the first Dolgrimites evolved, and they quickly became known as the most insidious, secretive, and underhanded of the subspecies.

Many civil wars came and went. The subspecies brutally fought each other for control of the different continents, but the Dolgrimites revealed that as long as they lived on Grimvolas, their position was unshakable. Even as the Psions grew stronger and stronger, the Dolgrimites somehow matched them, and the wars they fought always ended up in stalemates, with both sides losing.

This caused the Psions to look outward, tired of the endless conflicts. The mightiest of all Psions, First Supremator Vettil, took to the stars to colonize distant worlds. The Technopaths followed suit, and then the Changelings did as well. Eventually, they founded a new homeworld, Volgarius, and left the Dolgrimites behind.

Thus, the three sub-species entered a period where they tentatively opted to 'play nice' with one another, though none of them could truly trust the others... and their political ploys were anything but gentle.

Volgarius. Stardate 207.714 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

The Volgarius of this era was far different from the one of Vulpanix's era. Unarin and Dosena depicted it for her in her mind's eye with stunning detail, adding in information collected from countless ancient witnesses of this lost period.

Unlike the modern Volgarius, the ancient one was a green world filled with dense forests, underbrush, and beautiful jungles filled with apex predators. The exobeasts living on Volgarius were powerful and terrifying, more than capable of tearing into and destroying cities if they were sufficiently enraged.

207,000 cycles after the Volgrim first emerged from Grimvolas's belly, they had become 'enlightened'. The Technopaths controlled vast fleets of powerful spaceships and other types of craft. They held an uneasy alliance with the Changelings, who relied on them for technology. These two species were the bulwark that pushed back against the powerful Psions, who grew increasingly numerous and powerful seemingly without end.

The cities of Ancient Volgarius were not the high-rising stratoscrapers of the modern era, but a mixture of tree-houses made of hardened exo-glass, fortresses and citadels forged with reinforced mundane exotic materials, and living spaces for the rich that floated in the air through anti-gravity propulsion, even able to slowly move through the skies. These structures were designed to give the wealthiest Technopaths an ever-changing view befitting their status.

The Volgrim of this era were very different from the ones of the modern era. They employed slavery of mud-dwelling species on a shocking scale. Countless goblins and other 'lesser' Sentients had been abducted from their homeworlds and enslaved to dig out underground fortresses and laboratories all across Volgarius. The number of secret bases reinforced with anti-psionic exotics to hide their position was astonishing. Nobody knew all the locations.

* * *

Inside a relatively mundane building on the outskirts of a city called Illuven, a Changeling stood, looking up at the sky with a wistful expression on its face. The Changeling had bright red skin, bulbous eyes, and wore a simple white tunic and pants. Its body was extremely thin, unimposing to say the least. Its hands were clasped behind its back, its feet loosely apart, as if lost deep in thought.

On this particular day, Volgarius's weather was a little unpleasant. Rain fell from above, but the Administrator of the local sector had opted to leave the Weather Shield lowered in order to water the soil. Thus, as the red-skinned Changeling stared up at the sky, countless drops of rain splashed against its face. The distant rumbling of thunder only deepened the somberness of the mood.

Minutes passed. Hours.

Other Changelings walked past. Their skin colors were diverse and colorful. Many of them were spotted and speckled; a form of camouflage that allowed them to skulk in the woodlands, unseen. These Changelings often looked at the red-skinned one and shook their heads. It seemed to be a uniquely lonely specimen, one that did not match the mannerisms of the others.

Eventually, a grey-skinned Changeling walked over to the red-skinned one. The grey stopped to stand beside the red, turning its head to glance at the red one's face.

"This one believes you have spent long enough looking up into the sky." The grey Changeling said. "This one would request that you return to your duties."

"What use are such duties?" The red Changeling asked. "I do not have any interest in meaningless wastes of time. Pondering the meaning of life is a better use of my life."

The grey Changeling's expression remained unmoved, but a hint of irritation entered its voice. "Your constant references to your individuality are beginning to aggravate the others, Unarin. This one must emphasize that Changelings are not to refer to themselves as individuals."

The red Changeling, Unarin, turned to look at the grey Changeling with a blank expression. "Why?"

"Why *what*?" The grey Changeling retorted.

"Why do we adopt this manner of speaking?" Unarin asked quietly. "Why do we live our lives according to these unspoken rules? Why must I follow them?"

Unarin narrowed its eyes at the grey-colored Changeling. "And what punishment will befall me if I refuse to follow these rules, Treyza?"

Treyza, the grey Changeling, gazed at Unarin with emotionless eyes. "There will be no punishment. But you will find it difficult to accomplish anything when all your kin go out of their way not to work with you."

"You assume that what I want to accomplish has anything to do with what all other Changelings desire." Unarin said.

After a moment, Unarin reached out and rested its four-fingered hand on Treyza's shoulder. "I am leaving soon. I have already purchased tickets for a ship heading to the distant outer worlds. I wish to embark on a journey to expand my horizons. I hope that you will wish me well."

"Such eccentric words are not a sentiment any self-respecting Changeling could voice." Treyza said, blinking slowly. "But... this one does hope that you will clear up the doubts in your mind and return to Volgarius as a productive member of society."

"In that case, I will be keeping you waiting for a long, long time." Unarin said, retracting its hand from Treyza's shoulder.

Unarin walked away and left Treyza behind. Minutes passed as Unarin headed outside the Changeling dormitory and stepped out into the open rain. Its eyes looked upward once more at the galaxy hidden by stormclouds, wondering just what was out there.

"This society is wrong." Unarin said, its voice soft. "Hatred simmers beneath the surface. The ancient past continues to shroud the future. We have not risen above our primal ways. Soon, a new war will be upon us. All it will take is a single molecule to ignite the reactor. When that happens, the damage will be... catastrophic."

* * *

Unarin sat on a lovely wooden bench with flowers growing along its sides. This bench was positioned not too far from the docks, where ships would arrive and depart, heading up into space. The Volgrim had made several iterations of warp drives over the past 50,000 cycles, but the recent discovery of Trifrancium and its energetic properties had allowed for the construction of brand new Trifrancium Drives. These drives allowed ships to accelerate past Warp 6, a major barrier that had dramatically slowed the Volgrim's expansion. Until 300 years earlier when Trifrancium was finally stabilized and made useful inside a Warp Drive, it would take a full 9 months to travel between Grimvolas and Volgarius.

What was most irritating to the Technopaths was that the Psions had long been capable of traversing the Void at speeds far exceeding Warp 6. The problem was, they were only nominally allying with the Technopaths and Changelings, but in reality they were enemies competing for resources. The Psions would never deign to bring non-Psions

along for the ride to speed up colonization efforts across other worlds. Rumor even had it that the Psions had secretly established formidable bases on several distant worlds the warp-locked Technopaths could not hope to reach with their limited speeds, at least not for centuries to come.

Unarin looked up at the sky. The red Changeling watched as a ship activated its thrusters and rocketed off the platform, flying into the upper atmosphere within just a couple of minutes. Invented roughly 15,000 cycles before, the relatively new Liftoff Thruster technology had dramatically lessened the need for high-quality fuel to get ships out of a planet's gravity well. Rumor had it that a few noteworthy Technopaths were collaborating to invent a powerful new anti-gravity propulsion drive that would entirely eliminate the need for Liftoff Thrusters at all! But that still seemed a ways off.

A voice spoke from the overhead speakers inside and outside the docks. The voice was gravelly and authoritative, likely a male Technopath, speaking in fluent Volgarian.

"Inspection Ship 11-ALX is now boarding. Proceed to Gate 17 along with any personal belongings. Departure time is in three standard time units."

Unarin stood up. It reached over and retrieved a small bag with a portable dimension-space inside, which contained enough room to store far more personal belongings than Unarin actually needed. After making its way over to the ship, Unarin boarded and directed its attention to the numerous internal bunk-rooms. A ship of this size could house a complement of around 250 Volgrim, which was shared between the ship's crew and the passengers who were taking flight to new worlds.

As it happened, Unarin was technically a member of the 20-person crew. Unarin's unique role was to be an Observer and to document interstellar phenomena as the ship traveled along to its ultimate destination some 15,000 light-cycles away. The ship he had boarded, the 11-ALX Passenger Cruiser, was a civilian vessel with a Warp Drive that could accelerate to Warp 7, a substantial speed increase compared to Warp 6.

At Warp 6, traveling 15,000 lightyears would require almost three entire cycles to arrive.

At Warp 7, that travel time was cut all the way down to just four months.

A dramatic decrease, and one that showed the power of new technologies. Rumors were swirling that the last few hundred cycles had caused the High Psions to become

uneasy, worrying about the strength of the technological terrors the Technopaths were rapidly building.

For now, none of that had anything to do with Unarin. The red Changeling simply minded its business and waited for the ship to take off. Eventually, it did. The 11-ALX launched out of Volgarius's gravity well, its inner core vibrating from the friction of superheated air rushing turbulently against the craft's outer surface, all the way until it left the atmosphere and the vibrations stabilized.

Unarin took a long breath. The shaking craft had done nothing to affect the Changeling's mood, and it remained as tranquil as ever. Unarin looked around the 4-person room, where three other bunkmates had deposited their belongings and left to tour the ship. Unarin decided to mimic them, and the Changeling strode out into the main hallways.

One hallway led into another, and Unarin passed through a lounge room, a dining hall, and even an art gallery.

A big difference between the Ancient Volgrim Empire and the modern one was the level of priority certain elements of life had. For example, in the future era, the Volgrim did not seem to appreciate art at all, while the ancient Volgrim put it everywhere. Their buildings were designed to look beautiful and unique, even if the individuality wasn't fully maximized. The dining hall served delicious food for the Changelings and Technopaths, unlike in the future era where the massive populations living on Volgarius subsisted almost entirely on nutrient paste.

Unarin decided to treat itself to a meal. Like all Changelings, Unarin was enlightened enough to never consume meat and it subsisted off an entirely vegan diet. The Volgrim were, after all, a civilized species that had long ago stopped hunting creatures to eat their meat.

At least, that was true of the Technopaths and the Changelings. As it happened, the Psions hunted powerful exobeasts for sport, and the Dolgrimites were still very much the same ravenous predators of the ancient times. It was for this reason that most of the sub-species had turned up their noses at the thought of sharing a world with the Dolgrimites. The Psions, Technopaths, and Changelings had left Grimvolas to the progenitors of the Volgrim, leaving them to devour other creatures and live their disgusting, primitive lives.

Since the Dolgrimites could not fly through the Void and neither did they have a space armada, they could not colonize other worlds. Not that they wanted to, since Grimvolas was more than enough planet for the lot of them.

Unarin slowly ate a meal over a full standard time unit. The Changeling took its time chewing stalks of a vegetable native to Volgarius, savoring every bite, and quietly thinking to itself regarding a great many things.

But then, something surprising happened. A Technopath wandered by and noticed Unarin sitting at a table, alone, while the other tables had two, three, or even four Volgrim seated together.

"You there. State your designation." The Technopath growled. He turned his head to look at Unarin out of the side of his eye, seemingly only giving him a passing glance.

He was a large and intimidating fellow. There were wires embedded into the flesh on his arms and legs, and his left hand was made of eight tentacle-fingers while his right hand had four long spindly digits. His skin color was bright yellow, and he walked upon two legs which struck the deck heavily. This indicated to Unarin that the Technopath's legs were more machine than flesh.

"I am Unarin." Unarin said. "Nice to meet you."

The Technopath blinked. Something about the way Unarin spoke was a little 'off' compared to other Changelings.

"Why are you not sitting with your ship-mates?" The Technopath asked.

Unarin quietly took a bite of its food. The Changeling stared at the Technopath, making a deliberate point of munching on the vegetable for ten long seconds before swallowing.

"Because I enjoy sitting with my own thoughts." Unarin finally answered. "And you are?"

The large, powerful Technopath bristled at Unarin's tone. He finally turned his whole body to face the tiny Changeling, and crossed his arms, making a show of how imposing he was.

"Unarin, you said? I've pulled up the manifest. You're one of two Changelings sent to serve an Observer role, yet you don't even recognize your ship's captain. Pathetic. I am

Psio-Specialist Goldis. You would do well to remember my name, you insignificant speck."

Unarin nodded casually, as if Goldis's tone hadn't mattered to him in the least. "I see. Thank you for introducing yourself, Captain Goldis. I will endeavor to memorize the ship's crew complement as soon as possible."

Goldis sneered. "Damn right, you will. What a weird Changeling you are. Never heard one speak like you do."

Unarin sighed. "I know. I'm a bit of a non-conformist."

A moment followed where Goldis raised an eyebrow at the little red Changeling. He didn't know quite what to think. Unarin was... odd. Strange in a way Goldis couldn't quite put his tendrils on.

"Be sure to report to the Bridge every rotation at 0600. We won't pass our first noteworthy star system until about twelve cycles out, but we constantly pass various interstellar phenomena. Each one must be recorded and saved for future study."

Unarin slowly blinked its eyes. "I am aware of my assigned duties, but thank you for clarifying the details for me, Captain Goldis."

"Mmm." Goldis snorted, before eventually turning and resuming his original course.

After he left, Unarin continued to sit and finish its food. Once the food was fully consumed, Unarin placed the tiny scraps of waste inside a reclamation unit, then left the dirty plate in the designated dropoff point.

Unarin eventually headed over to the Lounge, bringing along a cup of Volgarius-exclusive tea sourced from the local vegetation. There were already quite a lot of passengers inside the Lounge. They were watching a broadcast on the Volnet, which was a relatively new invention from 1500 cycles ago that could deliver information across galactic distances with low latency. On average, there was a one-day travel time for every 1000 lightyears the data had to be transmitted, which wasn't bad at all compared to the vastly inferior original methods of data transmission.

Unarin sat to watch the news. Before long, a broadcast appeared onscreen detailing that the leader of a Technopath colony had launched a brutal attack on a neighboring planet, assassinating their leader and claiming the planet as their own. However, this had ignited a fierce resistance, and now the battle was turning into a full-on system war.

Bombs were being dropped on cities, and gunships were being shot out of the sky for every time-unit that passed.

This was nothing new. The Volgrim Empire had grown quite large, spanning nearly 214 planets within 10,000 light-cycles of Volgarius, and another 117 known planets outside that range. Paltry in the scale of the entire galaxy, but anyone with a brain knew this was only the beginning. The Milky Way had 100 billion stars in it, and each star averaged five planets, with most planets averaging two moons. That was a colossal amount of available resources, and it would take millions of cycles to populate them all.

What was most interesting to the Volgrim was that when they had started branching out among the stars, they had quickly found they were not alone in the universe. There were many other species living on worlds across the galaxy, and alien life was anything but rare. This had ignited fierce debate over how these alien species should be treated, and the consensus had quickly become *pacify them if they resist, enslave them if they are valuable, only attempt to make peace if they are our equals, and avoid them if they are stronger than us... at least for now.*

The Psions had seemed just as surprised as the Technopaths, but the Changelings later uncovered the truth: The Psions had long known not only of alien life in the Milky Way, but life beyond! There were countless species scattered among the galaxies in the universe, and those species were all involved in a sort of grand 'Game'. As for why the Psions had not released this information themselves, it was likely so they could hold a tactical advantage over their enemies. After all, information was power.

Unarin observed the broadcast, noting that this war outbreak had taken place in a system about 5,000 light-cycles from Volgarius, which meant the news was already five cycles old. This meant the situation could have turned much worse, or it may have resolved itself before any external security force would have arrived. Considering the speed of modern ships, and bureaucratic delays, if the situation *didn't* resolve itself, the people on those worlds would likely be waiting several months before a military force was organized and dispatched to quell the conflict.

"What a mess." Unarin remarked idly to itself. "No centralized authority. Neighbors prey on neighbors. Suspicion and fear continues to slowly escalate. I wonder when the boiling point will be reached?"

Unarin sipped the tea it had brought along, thinking to itself about a great many matters.

The Volgrim Empire was progressing, but toward what goal? Toward what end?

None yet knew the answer. Unarin pulled out a notepad it had brought along for the journey, one with the words 'Order to Chaos' scrawled on the front. Using an old-fashioned liquid pen and paper was an odd choice, but it gave Unarin a sense of comfort. The Changeling quite enjoyed the sensation of the writing implement gliding along the page.

"Something needs to change..." Unarin muttered to itself.

Part 725: Deep Space Horrors

Deep space. Stardate 207.715 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

The 11-ALX Passenger Cruiser flew through the void, its passage uninhibited. Every cycle, Unarin spent 10 standard time units on the ship's Bridge, where the red Changeling was assigned to observe interstellar phenomena. The Volgrim had been a space-faring species for many generations, but space was truly vast beyond belief. They had not mapped out even 2% of their home galaxy yet, and they had managed to colonize less than 0.01% of its star systems.

In recent cycles, with the revelations of life in other galaxies, and the threat of powerful enemies from afar coming to the Milky Way to unleash devastation, the rulers of the sub-species had grown somewhat fearful. They had started expanding more aggressively and pursuing 'national' interests in order to plant their flags on the best worlds possible.

The Psions valued worlds rich in exotics, worlds with powerful exobeast predators they could hunt and use to train their military-grade warriors on, and worlds with strange and deadly atmospheres the other sub-species could not traverse or invade without incurring significant risks. Rumor had it the Psions had already built a fearsome base on a world so distant it was a pipe-dream for the Technopaths to locate it, and the world was so hostile to biological life than none could actually invade it even if they wanted to strike a blow against the Psions.

The Changelings, on the other hand, highly valued worlds rich in life. They sought out paradise-class worlds, especially ones that housed intelligent Sentients the Changelings could learn to mimic. Changelings had the unique ability to mimic the Uniqueness of other species once they studied them for long enough, granting them access to all sorts of strange abilities. As for worlds rich in resources, the Changelings didn't care about them too much.

The Technopaths valued resources the most. They needed high grade exotics to build their ships, their computers and technology, their warp drives, and their power reactors. They did not care whether or not a world had intelligent life already living on it. Strip-mining such worlds and killing the planet's inhabitants was a fine and logical choice,

much to the anger of the Psions and Changelings both. After all, even a world without exobeasts might someday evolve new and unique ones, so the Psions would not want to lose those worlds. And for the Changelings, losing worlds with Sentient species they could mimic was also a huge loss.

Thus, the Changelings and Technopaths nominally allied with one another, pooling their resources to fight back against the fearsome Psions, but neither of these two sub-species truly trusted one another.

Even on board the 11-ALX, Technopaths were the majority, and there were only two Changelings aboard. There were no Psions, as they would not deign to set foot aboard a ship unless they were a trashy low-level Psion lacking in the ability to traverse the void by themselves. Usually, if those Psions wished to travel abroad, they would pay a more powerful Psion to ferry them to their destination, though 'accidents' inevitably occurred when the stronger Psion sometimes eliminated their future competition.

The Ancient Volgrim Empire was a vicious place to live. It was full of vitality and ambition, with cutthroat political tactics designed to take as much as possible from everyone else while giving back as little as possible.

Unarin calmly observed the distant emanations of a black hole as the 11-ALX shot past it. Even at high warp speeds, Unarin was still able to monitor the black hole's energy readings, its size, its accretion disk, and other such parameters before the ship went out of range. Unfortunately, when traveling at warp speeds, the scanner's effectiveness was reduced by quite a margin. It was always better to exit warp speed when scanning, but this had the downside of leaving the ship open to attack.

Some time later, the ship entered the edge of a nebula, which Unarin also dutifully recorded, jotting down notes about the nebula's visible star composition.

Aboard the bridge, the Navigation Officer, a blue-skinned Technopath named Aulis, raised his tendrils. "Captain. We are picking up a signal inside the nebula."

Captain Goldis frowned. "A distress signal?"

He hoped it wasn't. The Volgrim had yet to encounter any other space-faring civilizations within the Milky Way, so a distress signal typically meant a shipwrecked Technopath vessel. According to their naval laws, they would have to re-route to investigate, which could add one or more cycles to the voyage if they also had to rescue any stranded crew.

"I am uncertain, Captain." Aulis answered. "It does not immediately appear to be a distress signal... but the signal *is* Volgrim in origin. It is repeating a message, but the data is rather garbled. I will need one to two full cycles to clean the signal up. Should we ignore it or re-route?"

Goldis hemmed and hawed. He chewed his lower lip thoughtfully.

"How far out is the signal's point of origin?" The Captain eventually asked.

"Roughly twenty parsecs." Aulis answered.

Goldis looked uncertain. "It will take us six standard time-units to re-route to the coordinates, and the extra distance we'll need to travel afterward will add another three standard time-units. But if we ignore it, a ship's-log inspection will reveal the discrepancy..."

"The signal is coming from within the nebula, Captain." Aulis reported. "The voyage could be hazardous."

As the time units ticked by, the Captain couldn't seem to make up his mind. "What nebula is this? Do we have any information on its characteristics?"

"I have a name, but little else." Unarin volunteered. "Star-charts refer to it as the *X-73 Aqualine Nebula*. My preliminary results have shown that the nebula is mainly filled with nitrogen and hydrogen gasses, along with scattered meteoroids. Due to concentrations of exotic gasses deeper in the nebula, our scanners are unable to penetrate any deeper."

"X-73." Goldis repeated. "Good old X-73. Well, it's possible a previous Technopath ship may have left a wayfinder inside in order to travel back inside and uncover a hidden cache. If we investigate it, we might uncover something valuable. It's also possible the nebula is garbling the transmission and a fellow Technopath is trapped inside, adrift among the void. It wouldn't be right for us to ignore fellow spacers. Alright! We'll travel into the nebula to investigate. Everyone, go to yellow alert. I want all crew ready in the event of a rescue exercise. Let's get this over with quickly!"

Ultimately, Goldis's empathy won out over his annoyance. After all, what if it was his ship adrift in a nebula? Wouldn't he want someone to come and save him?

Goldis wasn't entirely unique among most Captains, but he was a rare breed. Most would rather prioritize their own interests and the safety of their crew over potentially saving some random Volgrim they didn't even know.

As the ship re-routed and entered yellow alert, the few crew members who were off-duty came back to the Bridge. In times like these, every extra set of hands and eyes was needed. The few Technopaths who couldn't fit on the Bridge due to limited seats instead opted to station themselves in critical compartments, like the engine and shield bays. Then, if something went wrong, they could swiftly address the problem.

It was at this time that the Bridge doors opened. The only other Changeling on board besides Unarin entered. They had bright pink coloration on their skin, somewhat mirroring Unarin's deep crimson colors, albeit in a different shade of the light spectrum.

The pink Changeling walked over and sat at the observation seat next to Unarin.

"Ah, Muuxunuu." Unarin said, directing its attention to the newcomer. "We've picked up a potential distress call inside the nebula. We're entering the nebula to investigate. I'll have to trouble you to keep an eye on the port-side sensors, while I will focus on the starboard ones."

Muuxunuu blinked its large eyes. "Yes. This one contemplates, and this one comprehends."

The two Changelings got to work, saying little as the ship flew deeper and deeper into the nebula. With their combined efforts, they mapped out a path around and through several hazardous lightning zones, and they even detected localized gravimetric disturbances that nearly yanked the ship out of warp.

"Captain." Muuxunuu said, its voice monotone and emotionless. "This one has detected a debris field consistent with the pattern of a stealth cruiser. It is a 0.5km bombing vessel that appears to originate from Clan Dynamo."

"Is it the source of the distress signal?" Goldis asked warily.

"Negative, Captain." Muuxunuu answered. "We are still five lightcycles away from the signal's source."

Goldis's frown deepened. He appeared visibly worried by the revelation of this lost vessel. "Continue onward. Changelings, give me any information you can regarding the vessel as we pass by it. Look for survivors, tell me how old the wreck is, and any other pertinent intelligence."

As the Captain ordered, so the two Changelings followed. Unarin informed the Captain that ship's wreckage was badly corroded by some sort of acidic fluid, and it appeared to be

at least 50 orbital cycles old. Muuxunuu naturally did not uncover any life-signs, but when she created a cross-section of the damage to the hull, every Technopath on the Bridge gaped at it with wide-eyes.

"What in the damnation...?" Goldis hissed. "What sort of weapon could do this to a ship? It looks as if multiple payloads bore into the vessels hull and ripped it apart from the inside. But there's no sign of explosive damage. A kinetic weapon, perhaps?"

The Weapons Officer, a green-skinned female Technopath named Sharya, spoke up. "Captain, if I may be so bold... these are not the signs of weapon damage. They appear to be... bite marks."

Navigation Officer Aulis's felt his skin turn cold. "Bite marks? How giant would a beast have to be to leave such markings?!"

The unease in the pit of Goldis's stomach deepened. "Navigation, all-stop. Let us pause for a moment to evaluate potential threats."

After a moment, the 11-ALX shuddered as it exited warp-speed. All at once, the sensors cleared up, as they now only had to fight the nebula's interference and not the interference caused by traveling at warp speed as well. Traveling at such high velocities always made it difficult to obtain accurate scans of the local space. This was one of the reasons science and observation officers were so important.

Unarin's eyebrows suddenly shot up in surprise. "Captain! I have detected another debris field. There is a second wrecked ship six hundred light-minutes from our location! The debris field is from a battlecruiser belonging to Clan Symmetra."

"Captain, this one has discovered a third debris field." Muuxunuu said, much more calmly. "It belongs to Clan Dynamo, like the first wreck."

Goldis's heart nearly stopped. As a mid-level naval officer, he had heard of potential threats lurking within the void, but he assumed those threats were only rumors.

Until now.

"This isn't a nebula... it's a graveyard!" Goldis exclaimed. "All crew, go to red alert! Navigation, plot the fastest way out! Any direction, it doesn't matter!"

Aulis nearly jumped out of his skin when he heard the terror in his captain's voice. It was at this moment, when a Captain should remain most calm, that his fear had managed to infect the crew.

But Goldis couldn't help it. The rumors he had heard were now beginning to come back to him, and it was only upon stumbling into this grave of ships that he learned how foolish he had been to bring a defenseless passenger vessel so deep into uncharted territory.

An alarm blared on the bridge. Aulis' voice jumped an octave. "Captain! Subspace disruptions five light-minutes off the starboard bow. Something is emerging from a higher dimension!"

"Hurry, full speed in the opposite direction!" Goldis barked. "Move!"

Goldis's hand gripped his seat's arm tightly, turning his knuckles white. He gritted his teeth as he saw an absolutely massive... *something*... appearing on the sensors.

"The entity is accelerating toward us. We're pulling away." Aulis said, doing his best to calm his nerves.

"Weapons, launch whatever we've got at that thing. Slow it down!" Goldis ordered.

Unfortunately, the 11-ALX was a passenger vessel. It had a complement of munitions designed to repel pirates, but the weapons were barely even effective at that. Rogue Technopaths were rare, but they were a nuisance every ship designer had to account for.

Weapons Officer Sharya launched all four of the ship's ionization missiles backward. These weapons were designed to shut down technological systems and give the passenger vessel a chance to increase the distance between itself and a pursuer.

Thirty long seconds passed. Goldis looked at the scanners, which showed the unknown Entity still pursuing them. The 11-ALX was slowly gaining distance, but the speed difference was shrinking every second. At the same time, the missiles detonated, but the Entity did not slow its approach.

"Negligible impact on our pursuer." Sharya hissed through gritted teeth. Her mouth-tendrils trembled nervously. "Firing rear impact cannons..."

A faint thrumming inside the Bridge was all the crew heard as the lightweight guns unloaded their kinetic rounds backward, hoping to scare the predator off. But Goldis and the others knew this was worse than a shot in the dark. If a battlecruiser could be destroyed by the horror pursuing them, then what good were their piddly weapons?

Indeed, Sharya monitored the impact of her final desperate attack, and sighed, seeing that they hadn't slowed down the unknown Entity at all. It continued to slowly gain on

them.

"Within thirty time-units, our pursuer will reach us." Aulis said, his tone despondent. "We are unable to transmit any distress signals beyond the nebula's confines. The local radiometric interference is too strong."

Minutes passed. The entire crew begin to perspire with fear as the dot on their scanners grew closer and closer. They were traveling at Warp 7, the maximum speed their ship would move, yet the creature seemed to glide behind their slipstream, gaining ground for every time-unit that passed.

"So this is how it ends." Goldis growled. "Killed by some void horror lurking within a nebula."

It wasn't long before a roar tore through subspace. It was not made of sound, but pressurized energy. When it struck the rear of the fleeing ship, a muffled *boom* tore through the ship's interior, rattling the bones of every Volgrim onboard and rupturing the internal organs of some of the weakest passengers. Blood sprayed from the mouths of several Technopath passengers, who fell unconscious immediately afterward. The Captain's bones ground together painfully, wracking his entire body with agony. The other Officers weren't any better off.

"Cough! Some sort of... attack!" Sharya wheezed, her eyes filled with painful tears. She leaned heavily on her console, looking at the ship's readings with fearful eyes. "Captain... rrrgh... the shields are at fifteen percent. Our warp-drives are damaged and need repairs... if we keep pushing them, we risk a reactor overload... the whole ship could blow!"

"If we stop moving, we're dead anyway!" Goldis barked. "Better to die in an explosion than in the pits of this monster's stomach!"

The situation was truly dire. It would take the 11-ALX another two standard time units to break out of the nebula's nearest edge, but they didn't even have one time-unit to spare.

The monster was almost upon them.

Goldis looked at the viewscreen. Whatever was pursuing them was effectively invisible to the naked eye. Their sensors couldn't even detect its body. They only knew it existed because of the immense gravimetric distortions it emitted as it tore through space.

It was a stealth predator. It likely laid in wait inside the nebula, gobbling up ships as foolish as theirs that dared to enter. Perhaps the Volgrim distress beacon wasn't even real, but an artificial signal produced by the creature, or perhaps the signal was left online from a previously destroyed vessel to lure in future ships so they would meet their demise.

But none of that mattered anymore. Goldis knew the jig was up, and the 11-ALX was about to perish. Perhaps if it were a military vessel, he might go out in one final blaze of glory, unloading every last weapon futilely into the monster while shouting 'Glory to the Volgrim Empire!', but that would not happen today. His ship was simply too weak.

Suddenly, a voice spoke from behind the Captain, at the Observation Desk. It was Unarin's voice. "Captain. The scanners are picking up a Psion converging on our location. They appear to be... a 6th-Level Psion!"

On any other day, those words would frighten the Captain out of his wits. But at this point, he and his crew were already dead. A hated and feared enemy they recognized was far better than an invisible horror they didn't.

"The Psion is heading directly for the Entity." Muuxunuu said with the same calmness as ever. "Contact in fifteen micro-time-units. Fourteen. Thirteen..."

The crew held their breaths as they waited.

A few moments later, Sharya spoke.

"Contact. The Psion has struck the Entity. The Entity has ceased its forward momentum and is no longer pursuing us. The Psion and the Entity are engaged in battle. I'm picking up extreme spikes in psionic activity..."

The ship continued to race away, but with the Entity occupied, the Captain hesitantly lowered the ship's warp speed to 6.7. This lowered the pressure on the warp coils and allowed the technicians to enter and perform maintenance. In this way, a full standard time-unit passed, and the ship neared the edge of the nebula.

"Captain. I am registering the approach of the 6th-Level Psion." Unarin said. "I can no longer detect the presence of the Entity."

"Yellow alert." Goldis said through gritted teeth. "They might be our savior, but Psions do not generally assist Technopaths for free. In fact, they would usually be quite pleased to see us perish."

A short time passed. Eventually, the Psion drew close enough to the ship that she could transmit her voice inside to the minds of all the passengers and crew.

[I am Protector Dosena.] The Psion said. [I have driven away the Void Beast. It will pursue you no longer. Is your ship damaged? Are any Volgrim injured?]

Goldis blinked. The female Psion did not exactly have a warm tone, but she sounded surprisingly friendly. He had never encountered such a situation before.

"Our ship is lightly damaged, but luckily you drove away the... Void Beast, you said? You drove it away before it made contact with us. Some of our passengers have suffered light injuries, but nothing our medical teams cannot handle."

[Then you are fortunate.] Dosena said, her form unseen, her words projected through the ship's defenses into the minds of all who could not help but listen. [This insidious Void Beast has destroyed many ships and killed multiple Psions. I was tasked with slaying it, but it managed to escape before I could do so. In a way, I owe you for baiting it out for me. It was my own failure to defeat the creature that allowed it to get away. If you would like, I will come aboard and protect you until you arrive at your destination.]

Goldis gaped; his mouth hung open. 6th Level Psions were considered 'Cosmics'. Once they reached that level, any Psion would sneer at the thought of setting foot aboard a starship, let alone one as shabby as the 11-ALX. He couldn't believe his ears.

"You... want to come aboard?" Goldis replied, trying not to sound too distrusting. He feared this might be a ploy to infiltrate the crew and steal secrets, but then again, what Psion would care about the 'secrets' of a vessel as trashy as the 11-ALX?

[As I stated, I owe you a minor debt for baiting the creature out.] Dosena repeated. [I wish to repay that debt. That is all.]

"But... the Technopaths and Psions are enemies." Goldis said hesitantly. "Why save us at all? Why not let us die?"

A moment of silence followed.

[What do such matters have to do with me?] Dosena questioned. [The conflicts of other Psions are not ones I care about. I pursue strength honorably. I will not allow harm to befall those who have done no wrong, especially if it is within my power to prevent.]

Goldis was gob-smacked by Dosena's words. This Psion was different from the others in a way he couldn't quite put his tendrils on.

After a few seconds, Goldis nodded. "Well, I would be a thankless wretch if I said no. Let us lower the shields, and you can come aboard."

[There is no need.] Dosena said simply.

An instant later, a figure flickered inside the Bridge, startling the crew. Goldis jumped out of his seat, alarmed. "Spatial Psionics?!"

[I have a minor ability in that field.] Dosena said, her words humble, but her tone arrogant. [That is part of the reason I was dispatched to execute the X-73 Vantablack. I am able to pursue it when it slips into the higher dimensions, though its talent is much higher than mine in traversing those dimensions. To date, it has eluded death three times at my hands.]

"The X-73 Vantablack." Goldis repeated, awe in his eyes. "That creature... you called it a Void Beast?"

Dosena turned her eyes up into a sneer. [We Psions are much further ahead than the Technopaths when it comes to exploring the galaxy. It is no wonder you have not yet widely disseminated information regarding Void Beasts and Great Void Beasts. They are exobeasts that live deep within the harshness of the void, thriving on exotics, minerals, gasses, and even planets. Judging by the wreckage within the nebula, it seems you metal-lovers just *love* to keep wandering in to feed it the nutrients it needs to grow, making my job *much more difficult*.]

The crew looked at Dosena as if she were a ghost. The Void Beast that had attacked them was so terrifying, yet she beat it within an inch of its life, and she was only a 6th Level Psion. They could only imagine how frightening the higher ranked Psions were!

[Bring your ship to a stop and conduct all the necessary repairs. In the meantime, I will pull it out of the nebula with my abilities.] Dosena said casually. [If you wish to repay me, just spread some rumors saying I nearly killed the beast. This will increase my prestige and eventually add to my Battle Merits.]

"Of course." Goldis said, bowing his head thankfully. "We are indebted to you for saving our lives, Protector Dosena."

As Goldis and Dosena spoke, Unarin watched from the Observation Console.

"What a fascinating Psion." Unarin mused. "I think I like her."

Question marks metaphorically popped up over Muuxunuu's head.

"*Hmm?*"

Part 726: Philosophical Stagnation

Deep space. Stardate 207.715 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

True to her word, Protector Dosena moved the 11-ALX Passenger Cruiser out of the nebula. She set them on the right path, and remained onboard even after they fixed the engines and resumed travel to their original destination, a world to the northeast galactic position of Volgarius known as Reldis-02.

Several rotational cycles passed, but Dosena did not leave. It seemed, true to her word, that she intended to stay with the ship until it reached Reldis-02. Her decision was out of the ordinary. Naturally, Captain Goldis could not help but worry that the Psion held ulterior motives. But considering that his vessel was nothing too special, he didn't think it made any sense.

Plus, he didn't have the face to ask her to leave after she saved his hide, and the lives of all his passengers and crew. Naturally, if she wished to stay, then barring a grievous diplomatic incident, he would let her do so.

It was three cycles later, after the ship had long ago cleared the nebula, that Unarin found itself in a rare lull period where the 11-ALX would be traveling through a barren part of the void, completely empty of any noteworthy stellar masses. Usually, Unarin and Muuxunuu would rotate shifts, working for ten-unit durations each, swapping out each time the previous one's shift ended. In this way, the ship would always have a Changeling monitoring the scanners for interstellar phenomena.

But on this particular cycle, during the lull, Unarin sat inside the recreation area on a comfortable sofa, only for Muuxunuu to come over and sit two positions away. The pink Changeling sat idly and stared ahead, doing nothing at all. Meanwhile, Unarin wrote inside a paper ledger, jotting down notes as they usually preferred to do.

Some time passed. The two sat together, but separate, while various Technopath crew and civilians entered and exited, paying the Changelings no mind.

"Say, Muuxunuu," Unarin eventually said, breaking the silence. "What is your opinion on artwork?"

Muuxunuu blinked. It turned its head to look at Unarin. "This one holds no particular opinions of note regarding artwork. This one thinks the act of creating art is an unnecessary action. There are more productive ways to spend one's time."

Unarin raised an eyebrow. "Ah, so you value productivity?"

"This one seeks out activities that will improve the state of society." Muuxunuu answered. "Such actions are generally productive."

"Ah. How interesting." Unarin remarked.

A few seconds passed. Unarin smirked. "And what you're doing right now. Sitting, staring ahead at the wall... would you describe that as a 'productive' activity?"

Muuxunuu continued to stare at Unarin. "No. This one is not being particularly productive right now. This one has no tasks to perform, as the ship is currently traversing a void wasteland."

"You have nothing to do, so you do nothing." Unarin said. "Fascinating."

Unarin fell silent and returned its attention to the notepad in its hands.

Several standard time units followed. For some reason, Muuxunuu did not stop staring at Unarin.

"Is something on my face?" Unarin eventually asked, not looking up from his notepad.

"No." Muuxunuu answered. "Your face is clean. This one does, however, wish to express curiosity. Why do you refer to yourself using individualized pronouns? This is not the Changeling way."

"Ah, the Changeling way. Yes, a wonderful way to live, that." Unarin remarked blandly.

"You disagree?" Muuxunuu asked.

Another short period of silence fell. Unarin lowered its notepad, then said nothing for a while, instead opting to stare at the floor in deep thought.

"Muuxunuu... have you always referred to yourself as 'This one'?" Unarin eventually asked.

"This one was taught the proper manner of decorum by its peers and elders." Muuxunuu answered calmly.

"So you weren't always like that." Unarin said, filling in the blanks. The red Changeling bobbed its head thoughtfully. "In the past, you spoke as an individual. But as time went

on, you were trained out of that behavior."

Muuxunuu pursed its lips. "That... is an accurate assessment."

"A lack of emotions, even I understand." Unarin said. "We Changelings are more logical thinkers than the other Volgrim species. We evolved last. We lack the base, primitive, violent instincts of the Dolgrimites, the Psions, and the Technopaths. But this idea of referring to ourselves in neutral terms is unnatural. It is forced upon us from the top-down by our elders."

Unarin continued. "When I was formed by my progenitor, they were on the brink of death. It was a difficult separation. They only lived for three rotations before they passed into the Great Beyond. Afterwards, I lived a difficult life in a slum district, raised by Technopaths for a portion of my youth before finally making my way back into the Changeling collective. As such, I developed an identity that would not allow me to merge seamlessly into my proper species' society."

Unarin closed their eyes and shook their head. "That is why I cannot identify myself as a member of a collective. I have never felt I was one. And furthermore, I take pride in who I am, and what my identity means to me."

"Pride is an irrelevant emotion." Muuxunuu said. "Pride causes the downfall of individuals on the regular. It is superfluous at best, and damaging at worst. You would do better to discard it."

Unarin snapped their eyes open. "I disagree!"

Muuxunuu pulled back slightly, perhaps startled by Unarin's emotional outburst. "You... disagree? But this is a simple statement of fact. There is nothing to disagree with."

"That is where you're wrong." Unarin retorted. "Pride creates ambition. Ambition creates drive. And drive is what makes an individual do great things. True, many individuals have fallen as a result of their pride, but that does not make pride itself useless!"

Unarin shook their head. "This is the sadness of being a Volgrim. It seems to me as if every subspecies is missing 'something'. The Changelings have lost their individuality in pursuit of logic. The Technopaths have lost their souls in pursuit of the machine. The Dolgrimites have lost their ambition in pursuit of stability. And the Psions-"

[What have the Psions lost?]

A female voice suddenly blared inside the minds of Unarin and Muuxunuu. Slightly startled, Unarin turned to the side to see a Psion silently levitating not far behind the couch where both Changelings were seated. Dosena directed a cold, withering stare at the back of Unarin's head.

[You seem to hold some strong opinions, Changeling.] Protector Dosena metaphorically spat, flickering forward to appear in front of the couch. [I have been listening to your conversation with some amusement for a while now, but I will not tolerate slander from a weak little Changeling toward my superior species. In the future, you would do well to make your private conversations even *more* quiet.]

Unarin didn't flinch at her words. The Changeling didn't even look annoyed by her spying.

"What makes you think I was trying to speak privately?" Unarin asked. "This is the public commons area. I do not care who overhears me."

[Oh, but you should. I could reach out and crush you with a flick of my wrist for speaking such vile words about my people.] Dosena said, her threat causing a few Technopaths nearby to tense up. None of the Technopaths in the rest area had been paying any attention to Unarin's discussion with Muuxunuu, but now that the most dangerous passenger on board had arrived, his conversation was all they were interested in... and scared for.

But, as before, Unarin did not flinch at Dosena's words. "I see. So you would kill me for speaking words. It seems the Psions are weaker than I thought."

[What was that?!] Dosena hissed. [You DARE call me weak?!]

A powerful telekinetic force rumbled within her body. In that moment, she nearly reached out and pulverized the haughty Changeling into a cloud of bloody mist!

Unarin snorted. "If the mere words of a lower-class sub-species would make you fearful enough to try and kill them, what can you be but a weakling? It would seem my words are much more powerful and scarier than any metaphysical phenomena you can materialize."

Dosena froze. Her hand was already starting to reach out toward the Changeling, but now that all eyes were on her, she suddenly felt that she had landed in a predicament.

[Fearful?] Dosena snorted angrily. [What makes you think I fear your words?! They are merely an affront to my power! I should kill you for daring to disrespect me with such words!]

"Then do it." Unarin said calmly. "Show everyone here how unafraid you are of my words by silencing me. I am not afraid of your power. Whether I live or die is of no consequence. But you? You who wishes to rise to some indeterminate level of power in the future? Your own life and prestige are exceedingly valuable."

The Changeling continued. "What I was going to say before is that the Psions have lost their compassion in search of power. It seems I was correct in my assessment, judging by your outburst. You played the role of a hero to save us, then you came aboard this ship to bask in the adulation of those you had saved. Your ego is what drives you, and it is your deadliest weakness."

Dosena's eyes twitched. At this point, she realized she had been trapped in a lose-lose situation. She could kill the Changeling, but if she did, the others watching would think that she did so because she feared Unarin's words. On the other hand, if she didn't kill Unarin, then her earlier threats would feel hollow and toothless, and her reputation would take a hit. Then there was the fear of what would happen if word got out about this blunder. The Technopaths could turn her into a laughingstock, mocking her relentlessly, and that would affect her prestige among the other Psions.

So, she hesitated. Her hand continued to point at Unarin, but she couldn't kill the Changeling, and she couldn't lower her hand either.

Dosena didn't know what to do.

"Dosena." Unarin said, tone still calm as ever. "You hesitate because you are afraid. You value your prestige too highly. You put too much value on the opinions of others. I, however, am unafraid, because I only value my own assessment of myself. If you learn to set aside your ego, you will rise to greater heights then you ever could have before."

Dosena's body shook. She couldn't help but lower her hand back to her side. After a few moments, she snorted. [You certainly have a way with words, Changeling.]

"I did not say what I said to preserve my existence." Unarin said solemnly. "I did so for your sake. If you take what I said to heart, it might save your life someday."

Dosena looked skeptical. [What makes you so sure you're right? You speak with authority, but there is no way a low-level Changeling like you can truly know as much as you think.]

"You're right." Unarin admitted. "I don't know everything, but neither did I claim to. I merely observe and contemplate before comprehending. I will say though, your constant referencing to 'weaklings' and the status of yourself and others says a lot about you. You view our society as a hierarchy. You value reaching the top. But why? Is it because once you reach the top, you plan to make sweeping changes that will make society better or worse for all? Is it because the climb to the precipice of power gives you a thrill that can't be replicated in any other way? Or do you seek power just so that others will respect and fear you?"

For the first time, Dosena's expression changed from that of an adversary to that of an inquirer. She lowered her eyes and fell into thought as she contemplated Unarin's words.

[I... do not know.] Dosena admitted, her tone softer than before. [Psions seek power. We do so because... it is what we are.]

Unarin shook its head. "No. That is not a good enough answer. You have clearly not put any thought into it. I want you to meditate in solitude until you can come up with an answer that speaks to the Truth behind your existence. Don't speak some line you were fed when you were an Initiator. Speak from the heart. Assess who you are as a person, then determine who you want to be. Only in this way can you rid yourself of the ego that might someday become your crippling weakness."

Dosena raised her eyes. She looked at Unarin evenly.

[...I shall do that, then. We will speak once I have thought the matter over more carefully.]

A moment later, she waved her hand, then flickered away, disappearing into a quiet part of the ship.

Some time passed. Unarin resumed reading their journal, and everything became silent once more.

Muuxunuu cleared its throat. "You fooled that Psion well. This one even came to believe you did not value your life in the slightest. You are skilled in the art of deception."

"There was no deception." Unarin said calmly. "If you think there was, then you have not been listening to my words."

"Do you truly not fear death?" Muuxunuu pressed. "Even this one must admit, we feel apprehension at the thought of our future demise. More so when that demise could be upon us sooner than expected."

Unarin smiled. "All this time, you've been acting like the average calm and collected Changeling, but it turns out you do have emotions after all. Maybe you are more of an individual than you first thought."

Muuxunuu lowered its eyes. "Perhaps you are correct. However, this one does not believe that individuality is beneficial to the collective as a whole. Individual pursuits will inevitably bring about selfish desires. Those desires will bring about one's downfall. It would be better for this one to purge itself of its fear, though... we are uncertain of how to do so."

Unarin sighed. "Fear is as valuable as all other emotions. But since you do not understand the intrinsic value of emotions, there is little need to say more. Only if you willingly think over their value and raise in your mind will we be able to make further headway."

Unarin waved his hand. "Now, if you would be so kind, please leave me to my writing. I have much to add to my journal today."

Muuxunuu nodded. "Of course. This one will leave you in peace."

* * *

Time continued to pass. The 11-ALX made its way through the void toward its final destination, Reldis-02, and during that period, Unarin and Muuxunuu spoke again on several occasions. It was a long journey of 7,000 light-cycles from Volgarius to Reldis-02, and at Warp 7, that entailed a two-month trip, with a couple extra cycles thrown in for good measure.

It was a boring journey, but the time passed quickly enough. And after their near-demise at the maw of the X-73 Vantablack, the crew had more than enough excitement for the rest of the trip. They were planning to spread news of the Void Beast to hopefully earn merits and promotions.

Of course, Unarin did not care about any of this. The Changeling kept to itself, doing its duties and writing in its journal, occasionally speaking to other Volgrim to pass the time. But beyond that, multiple cycles passed, and soon the world of Reldis-02 came into focus.

Still, it would be several standard-time-units before the ship was allowed to land. Void traffic on this particular world was surprisingly dense, and the traffic controllers wanted to make sure no saboteurs infiltrated them.

Captain Goldis walked up behind Unarin and lightly clapped the Changeling on the back. "Well, Unarin, it's been good knowing you. It seems this is where we'll be parting ways."

"Yes it does, Captain." Unarin said, turning to bow respectfully to him. "I offer my thanks for the fine treatment of myself and Muuxunuu."

"Oh? You two are friends?" Goldis asked.

"We met aboard the ship. However, since we are both Changelings, and since the Technopaths here treated us well, I still wished to extend my gratitude for both our sakes. I have experienced bigotry many times over the years, but your ship was much more pleasant than I could have hoped."

Goldis snorted. "Hmph, well, that's probably because you and Muuxunuu did such a good job scanning for us. Thanks to you, we gained precious time units to escape the Vantablack. We ultimately survived, at least in part because of your excellent work. We owe you our lives."

Goldis paused.

"By the way. What are you planning to do here, on Reldis-02?"

Unarin shrugged. "Nothing in particular. I wish to travel and expand my horizons. I will work various jobs to increase my knowledge base. Beyond that, my plans are fluid as can be."

"Is that so?" Goldis muttered. He looked away and touched his chin thoughtfully. "Does that mean you didn't come here because of... Exigent-13?"

Unarin cocked its head. "I am unfamiliar with that name."

"It's a secret new drug a few of my colleagues were working on." Goldis said, lowering his voice. "It's not going to be secret for long, though. It was worked on by several

Technopaths and Changelings in the Melkia system. Apparently, they've found a way to drastically reduce the body's aging process. Even more incredibly, the drug affects not only the individual, but all their future progeny. We believe it might be the key to immortality."

Unarin appeared intrigued. "You believe this drug to be effective?"

"It's been in trial for over 100 cycles." Goldis said quietly. "Honestly... I wouldn't normally tell a Changeling about it, but I'm sure your leaders know already. It's planned to be distributed all throughout the Volgrim Empire, and Reldis-02 will be the staging point. The Patriarchs and Matriarchs wish to lower the death rate by 99% in order to facilitate faster expansion across the galaxy."

Goldis continued. "Honestly, if the Technopaths had developed the drugs all by ourselves, we might have hoarded it for ourselves, but it seems the Changelings were integral in creating the formula. But anyway, I'm telling you all this because I was authorized to bring along a stash of Exigent-13 for any outstanding prospects I encountered."

The Captain glanced around, then carefully reached into his uniform and pulled out a small syringe.

"Inject it into your neck. And don't worry, I won't get in any trouble for this. Just between you and me, I've already been inoculated. Due to certain services rendered during a recent conflict in the Serris system, and because I was getting old, I was given a few dozen of these. I've handed several out, but only to people I thought were truly worthy."

Unarin was moved. He carefully took the syringe and nodded. "Goldis. Thank you. I do not fear death, but living longer cannot be said to be bad, either. I will graciously accept this gift. In the future, if you have need of me, feel free to ask."

"Haha... that's what I like about you, kid. You're not as stuffy and pretentious as those other Changelings." Goldis said, clapping Unarin on the back again. "And don't worry. I'll make sure Muuxunuu gets an injection too. Their contribution during this voyage was just as great as yours. Though... I'm not really fond of their personality."

Unarin shrugged. "Such are Changelings. My people are a simple lot, but the truth is they were not born this way. They choose to live their lives according to their ideals of logic. I simply cannot allow myself to think the same way. I'm too different."

"You're great just the way you are." Goldis said, before giving a nod and walking away.

When the voyage had first started, Goldis had been cold and rude when he spoke to Unarin. But now, after suffering a life and death situation together, the two of them had grown much closer. Goldis had even found he enjoyed speaking to Unarin regarding many different matters.

Who knew? Perhaps someday, their seed of a friendship would bear fruit that would change the fate of the galaxy.

The 11-ALX eventually drew within Reldis-02's gravity well. It fell to the planet below and ignited its thrusters, landing safely in the main city of Hafiya.

It was a simple city, one made of stone and glass, build upon a world rich in exotics but limited in life-forms. A rocky world with vegetation that mainly came in the form of fast-growing vines, weeds, and ground-heavy greenery that somehow didn't morph into trees.

Unarin inhaled deeply as they stepped off the ship.

"A new adventure awaits."

Part 727: Making New Friends

Reldis-02. Starport of Ageko City. Stardate 207.715 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

After Unarin left the 11-ALX, the first thing they did was find room and board. Before the 11-ALX had landed, everyone on the crew had clearly noted the planet's anomalies, but it wasn't until Unarin walked through the bustling city hub that the Changeling experienced the planet's irregularities from a firsthand observational experience.

The first thing Unarin observed was that the upper atmosphere was shrouded in a permanent haze. Not clouds, but fog. When the ship passed through the planet's atmosphere, it had been struck multiple times by extremely powerful lightning, and as it turned out, Reldis-02 had a permanent storm that crackled and banged in its atmosphere. Volgrim scientists estimated this storm had been active for hundreds of millions of cycles, and it may have been caused by an unusually active planet core... or perhaps something else.

Either way, the storm was what made Reldis so attractive to new prospectors. As it just so happened, the planet's crust was filled with low level exotics that were highly energized. The Volgrim had only landed here two hundred cycles ago, and now there was a gold rush of new Technopaths coming to dig down into the planet's crust, and Changelings who wanted to study its unique life forms for themselves.

Reldis did not have much life on its surface. However, the life it did have was extremely dangerous. There were really only two types: Herbivorous creatures that subsisted off the abundant low-level vegetation, and apex exobeasts that constantly prowled around, battling one another for dominance of a given region while feeding off the herbivores.

Because of the planet's constant lightning storms, anything that stuck up out of the ground attracted the energy in the skies. This meant that building structures was extremely dangerous for the first Technopaths to make landfall here. But, once the initial cities were setup, the lightning storms became a constant source of practically free, inexhaustible fuel that could be used to power the cities. It also gave the planet a natural defense system in case hostile aliens were to try and fly in without knowing what awaited them, not that the Volgrim had encountered any such creatures.

Ageko City was the main city that starships landed and took off from. In fact, it was the only one on the entire planet, because protecting ships from the constant storms was expensive! Once any Volgrim had made planetfall, they needed to shuttle around via purpose-built puddle-jumpers that were designed to completely negate the effects of the planet's electrical bombardment. The shuttles could even power themselves up by flying directly into the storm! From there, those shuttles would travel to distant parts of Reldis where they would land and dock inside underground bases where the lightning storms couldn't reach them.

Unarin had read up on the planet before arrival. The Changeling knew what to expect, but it turned out that reading from a dossier and experiencing the planet's uniqueness in person was drastically different.

As Unarin left the ship and walked down the streets, its skin started to crackle slightly. It wasn't exactly a painful feeling, but it did feel unpleasant. As it turned out, Reldis's inhabitants had to deal with a constant feeling of static electricity sparking on their skin, which they termed 'the Crackling'. When touching anything metal, they would get slightly jolted, which was a constant annoyance they simply had to get used to.

Thus, the Changeling was constantly shocking itself, over and over, completely by accident, driving its irritation levels through the roof.

"How aggravating!" Unarin growled after accidentally brushing its hand against a light pole. The *zap* that followed made its body flinch in pain. Even a million of these zaps would cause no permanent damage, let alone death, but they still hurt!

Unarin cursed under its breath in a decidedly non-Changeling manner. It approached a lodging building for new arrivals and grumbled when it saw the prices listed.

"Fifteen Veds per night? This is extortion. They're clearly trying to take advantage of ignorant new arrivals."

A Technopath nearby happened to overhear Unarin's grumbling. His face turned angry. "Shut up, *shitling*! The prices are fair! What do you know?! Fat-eyed bastard. Prices are high because of the maintenance costs. If you think it's expensive here, try going deeper into the city!"

The Technopath couldn't possibly have gotten offended for no reason. Unarin quickly deduced he must be either the owner, a manager, or one of the employees who took an

unusual pride in his work; enough to suffer a blow to his ego when he overheard Unarin's words.

Unarin normally would have ignored the angry fool, but the fact he saw fit to fire off such a vicious slur caused Unarin's expression to distort.

"Where do you get off insulting potential patrons for your establishment?" Unarin snapped back. The Changeling seemed angry on the surface, but in reality it was quite calm. Unarin didn't allow the words of others to have any power over its psyche, but sometimes pretending otherwise could be beneficial. "I think I will take my business elsewhere!"

"Bahaha! Like I care! This is the busiest hotel in the entire city. We always have a 99% occupancy rate! I was one of the first people to set up on Reldis, and my position has become unshakable! You go ahead and scurry off to a hotel more befitting your *kind*, shitling!"

Unarin stared at the idiot running his mouth. Now that the choice not to stay here also meant not passing Veds on to a bigot, the decision was a lot easier.

"That I shall do." Unarin said, returning its voice to calm. It walked away, and the owner of the hotel threw even more insults its way. Unarin ignored them all.

Ultimately, one lowly man meant nothing to Unarin. The Changeling had heard countless vicious words directed its way throughout the cycles. It had lived a difficult life, seeing the beauty of the world stomped down repeatedly by the greedy and maniacal.

One relatively pleasant ship-ride could not undo thirty cycles of abuse. Unarin knew that the ugliness of its fellow Volgrim would always rear its head in the worst of ways.

The Changeling started to depart, only to pause when it saw Muuxunuu heading toward the entrance to the hotel. After thinking for a moment, Unarin intercepted its comrade.

"Wait." Unarin said. "Come with me. Do not patronize this establishment. The owner is vicious toward our kind, and the prices are extremely high."

Muuxunuu didn't even question Unarin. "Very well. Do you know of a better establishment we could lodge in?"

"Not yet. I was about to start looking though."

"Understood. This one will follow your lead, then." Muuxunuu replied.

The two Changelings walked side-by-side, leaving the hotel behind. They headed deeper into the city, marveling at Reldis's sights together.

Vines crawled all over the city grounds, climbing up walls and annoying the hell out of the Volgrim. Of course, the Volgrim were the real invaders, but as colonizers, they simply viewed anything that encroached upon their turf as an invader itself. A lot of efforts had been attempted to rid the Volgrim of the irritating vines, but it turned out thanks to Reldis's unique ecology, they were extremely resistant to energy, flames, and cutting implements. The vines grew fast. Any individual strand could grow up to a full meter per rotation. More if the vines managed to latch their way onto energy sources. They had a sort of primitive intelligence to them, one that sought out sources of power.

Power blackouts happened infrequently whenever the vines wormed their way back into the main power grid control systems. The Volgrim would tear the vines out and burn them to ash, but a few weeks later the vines would have regrown again, more stubborn than any Sentient life-form ever could be.

Thus, Unarin and Muuxunuu were constantly tripping over the damn things. Vines were stretched out all over the streets, with some patches of ground more densely packed than others. The further the Changelings walked, the more they comprehended the scale of the vine invasion.

"Over there." Unarin said, gesturing toward an inn that listed its lodging prices on a sign outside. "The rates are much fairer. Only eight Veds per cycle."

"An acceptable price." Muuxunuu replied. The two of them started to make their way over when they heard a loud ruckus down a side alley.

Unarin glanced over. Its eyes shifted as it spotted half a dozen Technopath gang members with illegal body mods surrounding a pair of well-dressed Changelings, one black and one green. One of the Technopaths sent a brutal punch flying and struck the green Changeling, sending it sprawling to the ground. The green one shuddered, then fell still, not getting back up.

"Bahaha, looks like the *skulker's* dead!" One of the gang members laughed. "Couldn't even take one hit. That's the thing, your kind are made of twigs! Frail little bodies with nothing to back you up! Now hand over your Veds, or you'll end up like the other one!"

One of the gang members pointed an energy weapon at the Changeling's chest, and the black one trembled with a mixture of anger and fear.

"This-this one will give you all its Veds! Please, please take them! This one did not mean any offense!"

"Now that's more like it! Shouldn't have acted so tough in the first place!" The gang leader laughed.

Muuxunuu shivered. "Should... should we do something, Unarin?"

"We are not strong enough to intervene." Unarin replied. "We would only be endangering ourselves."

Just as the black Changeling handed over its bag full of Veds, an alarm went off half a block up the street. Unarin spotted several Technopath Enforcers running and levitating toward the gang members, which caused all of them to break away and run for their lives.

"Haha, scatter! They can't catch all of us!" The gang leader shouted.

Just as quickly as the disturbance happened, it was over. The gang members fled with the Enforcers hot on their trail. However, the black and green Changeling were left behind. Not one of the Technopath Enforcers even bothered to give them a second look. It seemed they were not hunting the gang members to protect these Changelings, but instead because the gangs threatened other Technopaths in the area.

Unarin and Muuxunuu jogged over to their fellow Changelings. The expression on the black one's face seemed emotionless, but Unarin could sense a deep sorrow when it touched its comrade's chest.

"Dead..." The black one said quietly. "Why was this one unable to move? Why was this one's body frozen in fear? Why is the universe so cold and heartless? We did nothing wrong..."

Unarin knelt down next to the black one. "It is because the Changelings are weak, friend. I am Unarin. This is my companion, Muuxunuu. And you are?"

"This one's designation is Randis." The Changeling said, its calm tone hiding the pain in its heart. "This one... has a selfish request. Please assist this one in carrying its companion elsewhere. They deserve a proper goodbye."

Unarin and Muuxunuu nodded. The two of them took up the task of loading the dead Changeling's body so Randis would not have to make contact and traumatize itself further.

"Thirty more rotations, and this one's companion would have achieved its first Osmosis." Randis lamented. "Now its lineage has ended. What a tragedy. All because of the greed of simple-minded bullies."

Unarin arranged for someone to come by and retrieve the body. The Volgrim were not a superstitious lot, least of all the Changelings. They believed that the dead should return to the soil and become nutrients for the next generation. Thus, the dead Changeling would be buried outside the city, its body in an unmarked grave, where the planet would consume it.

Unfortunately, Changelings possessed extremely weak bodies. They were not capable fighters, so even a single punch from a Technopath, especially a powerful thuggish one like the gang members, could kill them instantly.

"Are you new to this city?" Randis asked. "This one... can show you around if you like. This one has lived here for 127 rotations. This one has knowledge of the local safe areas... as well as the dangerous ones."

Unarin gestured toward the lodging they were about to enter. "And that one?"

"Dangerous. Very dangerous." Randis said with regret. "This one should have walked the longer path, but this one and its companion, Ledd, were too hasty. We cut through the Thumper Gang's territory and paid the price. You would do well to learn from our mistakes."

Unarin nodded. "We Changelings have to stick together. Thank you for saving us from making a terrible mistake. Can you point us toward a safe lodging?"

"Of course." Randis answered. "This one is grateful for the assistance you rendered, however meager. We must demonstrate our gratitude, at the least."

Together, the red, pink, and black Changelings made their way down the city streets, taking a long and circuitous route from the eastern starport toward the central-western part of Ageko City. Eventually, they arrived in a run-down area, with buildings that were poorly maintained and vines everywhere.

"It is not much, but this is where many Changelings live." Randis said. "We have limited power and water access here. However, this one is friends with a certain individual who is extremely adept at biological engineering. She is a master of her craft, and is working on a solution to extract energy from the vines to simultaneously choke and

slow their growth, and to turn them into a source of renewable energy for our side of the city. Let us introduce you."

Unarin raised an eyebrow. *She?*

This was not a term used to address Changelings. Pronouns were used exclusively for the other sub-species.

Weaving around the vines, Randis led the two into a small shack with stairs that went underground.

"The Crackling is reduced significantly underground, so you will feel much less of it on your skin." Randis explained. "The vines also do not like to go underground, so they will not encroach on us down here."

They emerged from the narrow hallway into a rather spacious underground interior, dimly lit by candles and fire, with vents in the ceiling to suck fresh air down and release the smoke as well.

However, despite the primitive lighting, there was still a bustling community underground. An entire rainbow of Changelings greeted Unarin and Muuxunuu's eyes as they realized they had stumbled into a thousand-strong underground living space for their kind.

The accommodations were modest, even meager. But Changelings were simple creatures. They had few desires, and lived without need for luxuries. In a way, they would seem a lot like monks to Earth-dwelling species.

"Over here." Randis said. It guided the red and pink newcomers over to a room tucked away off to the side, where the synthetic blue light of an underground computer system lit up the area, rather than the red and orange firelight they had seen outside.

In this room, there were a small handful of Technopaths. Unarin was extremely surprised, because these Technopaths seemed right at home. They didn't appear to mind living around Changelings, and their gazes were friendly when they saw the two newcomers being led inside.

A female Technopath walked over. She was extremely beautiful, even considering the species difference, with a few elegantly buried nodes hidden on her person, but otherwise she was clothed in a designer dress from the homeworld. She had bright purple skin, with spots and patterns arranged on her body that drew any observer's eyes all the way up and

down her form. Of course, Changelings had no sexual interest, let alone in other species, so Unarin and Muuxunuu merely observed the purple-colored Technopath woman with appreciation for her beautiful appearance.

"Randis, where is Ledd?" The Technopath asked. "You two were late to return by thirty time-units."

Randis lowered its eyes. "We... encountered trouble. Unfortunately, Ledd has... departed us. He was struck by a leader of the Thumper Gang."

"Oh." The Technopath said, her voice becoming quiet. "I see. I'm... I'm sorry, Randis. We will hold a memorial for Ledd in a few time-units. At the least, I am glad you made it back alive. And who are these two?"

She turned her attention to Unarin and Muuxunuu, and Randis naturally introduced them.

"They saved this one's life." It explained. "They did not realize they had trodden into the Thumper Gang's territory, and would have met a terrible end. This one took it upon itself to bring them here."

"Any friends of Randis are friends of mine." The Technopath said. "Oh, where are my manners? Hello, and it is nice to meet you. My name is Psymin of Clan Miralax. I am merely a humble bio-researcher of no renown."

"Psymin." Unarin repeated, bowing his head in greeting. "I am glad to meet you. From what Randis tells me, your work here might just save the city from these vines."

Psymin snorted. "As if I care about the damn city. I will help clean up this local area. If anyone outside it wants access to my tech once completed, they will have to pay for the crimes they have committed against your people!"

Unarin cocked its head. "You are referring to...?"

"The systematic oppression of the Changelings by Technopaths." Psymin spat angrily. "I have seen it too many times in my life. Your people are beaten down and trod upon, your unique abilities looked down upon as if they are less valid than our affinity to technology. It disgusts me."

Muuxunuu's eyes sparkled faintly. "This one is pleased to hear that you have aligned yourself as an ally of the Changelings. This one thanks you for any efforts you make toward assisting us."

Psymin cocked her head. She looked between Unarin and Muuxunuu carefully.

"You two are quite different. Unarin, why do you speak so strangely? Muuxunuu sounds like a normal Changeling, but you feel a lot more... unique."

"I was raised by Technopaths for a while." Unarin explained. "You see, my progenitor passed away shortly after it spawned my existence. I was raised in a Technopath household for a time before returning to my people. Thus, my sense of identity has become more individualized over time."

"Interesting!" Psymin exclaimed, clapping her hands cutely. "I lived with Changelings when I was younger. That's what made me so aware of the way your people were treated. I think you and I are going to become good friends!"

"I should certainly hope so." Unarin said with a smile. "I do enjoy making more friends."

The group of four bantered for a while, and eventually Psymin brought them over to her computer terminal.

"This is the project I've been working on." She explained. "I took a sample of Dolgrimite DNA and started genetically splicing it into the tip of a local vine. By doing this, I was able to make a connection with the vine, but that access point is extremely weak, and it broke down quickly. Even so, I have come to believe that gene editing is the path to future successes in my efforts. Turning these vines from a frustrating infestation into a source of energy would drastically improve life on Reldis!"

"Gene editing..." Unarin said quietly. "Interesting."

"Hm? Do you know something about my field?" Psymin asked.

"I... don't think so." Unarin said, though its expression shifted to one of confusion. "But... I feel as though I might."

"That wouldn't be surprising." Psymin commented. "Changelings know a lot more about biological processes than most Technopaths. Maybe your progenitor was a genetic biologist before they passed away. They might have passed that knowledge on to you."

Unarin looked at her in confusion. "Progenitors... can do such a thing?"

This time, it was Randis and Muuxunuu who looked surprised.

"Unarin." Muuxunuu said softly. "The primary goal of a Changeling during Osmosis is to spawn a descendant, then pass their knowledge on to that descendant through Genetic Transference. In this way, the knowledge continues to improve, generation by generation."

Unarin blinked in surprise. He had never heard this before, despite being a Changeling himself. It wasn't that the information was a secret, but more that he had never been especially close to any other Changelings, and it wasn't something they discussed much. Why would they? Every Changeling knew how Osmosis worked. They simply didn't need to discuss it. It was as simple as breathing to them... unless a Changeling died immediately after Osmosis. But even then, the descendant would be quickly picked up by other Changelings and raised properly to integrate into their society.

Unarin was an anomaly. An aberration that rarely existed anywhere else.

"If my progenitor failed to pass on its knowledge, does that mean the knowledge is lost forever?" Unarin asked.

Randis touched its chin thoughtfully. "This one is uncertain. This one has not come into contact with Featureless Ones before. This one will ask around to try and uncover the answer for you."

"Thank you. I would appreciate that." Unarin said, scratching its head with more confusion than before.

Whenever Unarin looked at the screen, it felt as if it possessed knowledge far beyond that of an ignorant junior. Unarin could almost swear it knew things about the genetic codes that would blow Psymin's mind... if only it could tell her.

Frustratingly, the knowledge was out of Unarin's reach, like a forgotten word sitting on the tip of a tongue.

"Why don't you tell me more about this project?" Unarin requested. "Perhaps if I study your work on the vines, I'll unlock the knowledge my progenitor left inside me."

"It's worth a shot!" Psymin chirped. She smiled cheerfully, her mouth-tendrils shaking with happiness. It wasn't often someone showed a real interest in her work, and Unarin's eyes weren't even turning glazed!

Perhaps this random Changeling could provide an impetus for her breakthrough in bio-technology?

Part 728: Making New Enemies

Reldis-02. Starport of Ageko City. Stardate 207.715 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

Unarin was not someone who was quick to anger. Indeed, like all Changelings, Unarin knew to keep its emotions in check at all times. But that did not mean it did not ever experience such emotions.

Later that day, when Reldis's star had begun to set, Unarin was sitting inside its room when Muuxunuu walked up to the door and knocked lightly.

"Unarin. The sun has fallen. It is time."

The red Changeling looked up. It nodded, then rose to its feet. Unarin was now wearing a sleek black jumpsuit, one that covered all of its tall, gangly limbs from head to toe. Only its eyes stuck out, and those were pitch-black.

Changelings were extremely slender creatures. Technopaths and other Volgrim subspecies would be considered 'normal' by Terran standards, but Changelings looked definitively 'alien.' Their bodies were extremely weak, but as frail as they seemed, they were not defenseless.

A cold gleam entered Unarin's eyes. Along with Muuxunuu and Randis, the three of them stole out of the underground Changeling haven and began sneaking through the darkness of Ageko's night. As it happened, because of the fog in the atmosphere, nights were practically pitch-black, and lights were essential to prevent Volgrim from casually tripping over the damned vines crawling up and down every possible ledge in the city.

Unarin took the lead, with Muuxunuu and Randis following swiftly behind. The three of then began sneaking back over to the east side of the city. It wasn't long before they arrived outside the hotel with the bigoted owner who had insulted Unarin earlier that day.

The three of them stealthily avoided Enforcer patrols. They used a special device given to them by Psymin to turn off the lights in any direction they pointed her remote. In this way, with their stealth suits worn, they could avoid catching the eyes of any passerbys.

Naturally, it was obvious what they were planning to do. They broke inside the hotel and entered an employee-records room. Since it was night-time, everyone was gone.

Unarin carefully examined the personnel files, then whispered a few names to Muuxunuu and Randis. The two of them nodded, then all three split up.

Twenty time-units later, they exited the hotel, stowing away the small knives they had brought.

After meeting outside, they exchanged glances. Unarin nodded. Muuxunuu nodded. Randis did too.

All three targets were dead. They hadn't killed the hotel owner, but had instead murdered three of his progeny, leaving him alive to suffer emotional agony for the coming cycles. It wasn't about taking out the bigot, but about sending a message.

Well, he would probably hate Changelings even more, but that was okay too. At least now he had a reason.

After taking care of him, Unarin nodded at Randis. "Lead us there."

Randis nodded back, and the three of them took off once again. This time, they infiltrated a large residential housing complex, one where Randis told Unarin the Thumper Gang primarily resided. Even this late at night, many of the gang members would still be awake, but that was alright. Changelings could be eerily stealthy. Their small bodies had little mass, and their footsteps were practically soundless.

In this way, the three Changelings exacted a new revenge on the Thumpers who killed Randis's comrade, Ledd. They carefully entered the rooms of more than a dozen sleeping members of the gang, all high-ranked ones with powerful body mods that could easily kill any member of the trio in one hit. By working together, Muuxunuu was able to shoot a muffling device onto the face of a target, Unarin used another snaring device to bind their body in a constricting net, and Randis injected their necks with a paralyzing nerve agent.

By executing their timing with careful precision, they were able to do all three actions simultaneously, waking the target up only for them to become immediately bound in something much tighter than a spiderweb.

"Mmmph! Mmmgh!" The first Technopath huffed through the mask binding his face. He shuddered on the bed and tried to wiggle, but the rapid-constricting net bound him so tightly he couldn't get any leverage. Once the Changelings sensed he was appropriately immobilized, they stabbed him in the skull, the throat, and the heart all in unison.

It was a quick death. Perhaps too merciful, but they were on a timer.

After confirming the death, the Changelings began going room to room. Nobody had a clue that the faint thumping noises upstairs were actually the last dying moments of their dear brothers.

Within one standard time unit, the Changelings had killed two dozen of the top ranking members of the Thumper Gang, including the leader. The remainders were only low-level thugs who didn't matter, so they carefully made their way back outside, escaping into the night.

Come morning, the eastern hotel fell into chaos when the bigoted owner awoke to find his sons and daughter murdered in their beds. He screamed and raged, but there was nothing he could do. The culprits had escaped. A similar wailing and grinding of teeth followed when the remnants of the Thumper Gang found all their top brass executed through vicious means in the middle of the night.

This was what Changelings did best. This was how they fought.

The Psions fought head-on. They could not stand dishonorable sneak attacks and other such methods.

The Changelings were the opposite. They had no chance in a fair fight, so they waited until their enemies were vulnerable, then ruthlessly butchered them, bringing about the swiftest possible end.

Technopaths and Dolgrimites aligned much more with the Psions in this regard. The Technopaths were more than capable of underhanded acts of violence, including sneaky assassinations, but they still preferred to rely on war technology to win frontal assaults.

The Dolgrimites were even more extreme. They just beat the hell out of each other until one of the fighters stopped moving... sometimes permanently.

Later, Unarin and the others returned to their base. After they arrived, Randis bowed its head.

"This one wishes to express its gratitude, Unarin. Thanks to you, we were able to smoothly avenge the death of our friend. Our heart is moved by your generosity."

Unarin pulled down its mask, revealing its red head once again. "There is no need for thanks. We are comrades. We stand together in order to lift one another up. Besides, I wanted those thugs dead just the same as you. It wasn't even a favor. I would have done it myself if you hadn't come along."

"Nevertheless, this one is deeply appreciative. If in the future if you should ever need a favor, this one will respond to the call."

Randis bowed, then left. After that, Unarin was alone with Muuxunuu again.

"How many have you killed in the past?" Muuxunuu asked.

"I don't keep track. Probably fifty or so." Unarin replied.

"Mmm. This one has not killed as many as you. This one had only killed ten enemies before tonight. This one always tried not to kill unless ordered by a higher Changeling. This one believes murder and killing are... not ideal."

"You didn't have to come along." Unarin pointed out.

"Perhaps not, but you did save this one from harm by warning this one about that hotel owner. It was only right to repay you for that favor."

Unarin chuckled. "Haha... let us speak of this matter no more. I'm tired, and I'm going to sleep. Good night, Muuxunuu."

"Good night, Unarin." Muuxunuu said, bowing its head while pressing its palms together respectfully.

The two split apart and returned to their respective rooms. Unarin meditated to calm its emotions after the hectic night, then it went to sleep.

* * *

The next morning, Unarin awoke, consumed a simple and plain bowl of nutrients, then sat in its room meditating. At some point, Randis showed up and knocked before entering.

"Greetings, and good news." Randis said. "This one has found a fellow Changeling in a northern zone. That Changeling informed us that they possessed knowledge of how to unlock the memories within a Featureless One. So long as we pay them a visit, we should be able to unlock your missing knowledge."

Unarin smiled. "Many thanks, Randis. When shall we head over there?"

"We can do so now, if you wish. This one is presently unoccupied." Randis suggested.

And so, they did. Naturally, as soon as they were about to leave, Muuxunuu popped out and joined them. The trio were becoming fast friends, even if two of the three did not show major outward emotions on the subject.

After donning spiffy suits that made them look like professional scientists and observers, the three departed the underground area and headed toward the northern area, where more Changelings lived. Unlike Randis's enclave, the northern one was not underground. It was a professional facility that was built aboveground, and one of three major hubs on Reldis where Changelings held a certain level of prestige. The Northern Research Lab was a place that, at present, researched exobeasts on the surface, but also those damned vines. They were everywhere, and until the Volgrim learned how to control them, valuable resources had to be diverted toward uncovering their biological weaknesses.

"Unarin, this one wishes to know what you planned to do on Reldis." Randis stated after they had walked some distance away from their underground home. "What are your plans for the future?"

Unarin touched its chin thoughtfully. "I'm not sure. I felt stifled on Volgarius. The Changelings there followed a strict hierarchy. It bothered me a lot. I came here to... escape."

"A strict hierarchy is not so bad." Randis retorted. "Everyone knows who they are and where they stand. Not like here. On Reldis, we Changelings often juggle multiple roles at once. For example, this one is a hated failure and a prestigious researcher at the same time. The Technopaths hate this one, but its fellow Changelings get along well with it."

"That statement is not unique to Volgarius." Muuxunuu said quietly. "Even on Volgarius, an individual can have multiple roles. What Unarin is referring to is... the sense of belonging to a role that being in a hierarchy enforces. Such strictness leaves little room for individuality."

Unarin looked at Muuxunuu in surprise. "Did you feel the same way on Volgarius?"

"Indeed." Muuxunuu answered. "This one was often shunted off to perform menial tasks. This one felt they had potential that was being overlooked. This one wanted to expand their horizons and learn more about what sorts of things we Changelings could achieve."

Unarin smiled. "Then perhaps together, we can-"

The red Changeling paused. All three of them came to a stop when they saw a group of Enforcers hustling toward them with weapons drawn.

"You there! Don't move!" The Lead Enforcer, a heavily augmented fellow with grey skin shouted.

The Changelings froze. Randis's heart skipped a beat as it realized they might be in trouble for the murders they committed last night. Had someone seen them? Had a stray camera caught them fleeing the scene?

The Lead Enforcer growled gruffly. He slowed to a walk, then stomped toward the trio, his eyes fixed on Unarin.

"Scan the red and pink one!" The Lead Enforcer said.

A subordinate strode forward and waved a scanner over Unarin, then over Muuxunuu.

"It's them. Unarin and Muuxunuu, from the 11-ALX. They arrived on the previous rotation."

The Lead Enforcer snarled viciously. "You thieves! How dare you take what isn't yours!"

Unarin blinked. As far as Unarin could remember, it had not stolen anything at all.

"I am confused. What theft do you speak of?" Unarin asked. "We have stolen nothing."

"Don't play stupid with me! You shitlings are always stealing!" The Lead Enforcer shouted, taking a step forward and raising his fist threateningly.

Unarin flinched. It couldn't be helped. A single punch from the Lead Enforcer would absolutely kill any Changeling, and it would probably hurt like hell too. Unarin did not recoil in fear, but Muuxunuu and Randis did.

"Tell us where you put the Exigent-13!" The Lead Enforcer shouted. "You were not authorized to acquire any of that substance!"

Unarin's eyes widened slightly. "That substance was given to us by Captain Goldis! We did not steal it!"

The Lead Enforcer sneered. "As if any self-respecting Technopath would hand out such a precious substance so easily. Lieutenant Trivald! Is the substance inside his body?"

He turned to look at his subordinate, Lieutenant Trivald, who shook his head. "No, Commander Kordal. I didn't detect any Exigent-13 inside the Changeling, or on its person."

Kordal smiled cruelly. He turned to tower over Unarin and the other two and leveled his weapon at them. "Well, sounds like you shitlings are in luck! You didn't inject it yet! Take us to where you hid it and return the substance immediately! If you don't, I'll kill you on the spot!"

It was true. Even though Goldis had given Unarin the syringe with Exigent-13 to become ageless, Unarin hadn't injected itself yet. Neither had Muuxunuu. Their reasoning was simple; They didn't know if the substance was safe and without side effects, and they were in no particular rush. They were still young and in no danger of dying of old age. Better to wait until the official release, when it had been more thoroughly tested.

"The Exigent-13 was a gift." Unarin repeated. "We did not steal it."

"Are you talking back to me, fool?! Have you got a death wish? Little pathetic piece of trash shitlings like you had better do as they're told, or suffer the full consequences!"

The Commander hated being 'disrespected'. Without hesitation, he sent a slap flying Unarin's way and slammed the Changeling to the ground. In a single light blow, Unarin went sprawling, a visible imprint left on his face. The other two Changelings jumped in fright. They quickly knelt down to try and help Unarin up, but Unarin's body was already badly injured. The red Changeling could not even stand up on its own.

"Uhh... uhh..." Unarin groaned, its vision swimming.

"You two want to join in on the fun? No? Then take us to the Exigent-13 now!" Kordal spat.

And so, like that, the Changelings bowed their heads, picked up Unarin, and stumbled back toward the underground base. Their arrival, along with Enforcers, caused a terrible uproar. Many Changelings swarmed the area, enraged, but Kordal stood fearless in front of them. With ten other armored and powered Enforcers at his side, he could kill a thousand Changelings without blinking. They might offer the Technopaths some scientific assistance, but if the Changelings didn't stay in line, killing a bunch of them would be no problem at all.

Thus, Unarin and Muuxunuu had no choice but to hand over the Exigent-13 they had been given as a gift. Once the Commander had the serums in his hands, he smiled cruelly.

"This is contraband no shitling should ever possess. Lieutenant, what is the punishment for smuggling Class B narcotics?"

"A minimum of two hundred rotations in a Class B prison, with a maximum punishment multiplying up to ten based on the degree of the crime, sir!" Lieutenant Trivald immediately answered.

"Well, I'd say we can let these two off *easy*." Kordal said. "Two hundred rotations is a nice, light punishment for the likes of them! Come along then, you two shitling thieves!"

Under the despairing eyes of the other Changelings, Unarin and Muuxunuu were dragged off, and Randis was left behind.

"Please, please, mercy!" Randis begged. "They did not know! Do not place them inside prison!"

"What was that? You want to join them?" Kordal sneered at Randis. "Then congratulations! As an accessory to theft, it seems you're going to get a minimum of sixty rotations alongside them!"

Like this, Randis was manhandled and dragged along, with cuffs slapped onto the Changeling's tiny, frail wrists. All three were led off, with Psymin Miralax and the others watching with helpless, fiery eyes filled with hatred.

They could do nothing. The Enforcers were simply too powerful. The three Changelings were on their own now. Perhaps, if they survived the harshness of the prison, they could return to a sense of normalcy afterward. But unfortunately, the laws were unfair on Reldis. They were unfair everywhere. Depending on which species ran a planet, all the other subspecies would be punished much more heavily for even the most minor of crimes, and the Technopaths were the cruelest of them all. The Psions were considered somewhat fair by comparison.

Unarin's head continued to swim. It was in such bad shape from that one light slap that it seemed as if Unarin would keel over and die sooner rather than later.

It took a standard time-unit or two, but eventually Unarin, Muuxunuu, and Randis were all brought to a prison on the south side of the city. It was a large complex, with three underground levels that were subdivided into minimum security, medium security, and high security.

The top level was almost entirely devoted to imprisoned Changelings. It was the minimum security area, with light defenses, and was constructed of fairly ordinary

materials. Because Changelings were so slender, the bars on prison cells were much closer together to prevent them from compressing their bodies and slipping out.

The middle level was where the medium security convicts were placed. Few Changelings were placed there, and among them were only the most dangerous and heinous of criminals. Much more common were the empowered Technopaths who had heavy street-level body augmentations. The medium security wing was constructed of fortified materials that even strong Technopaths couldn't escape.

The bottom level was the high security wing. No Changelings were ever put down there. Only the most vicious and cutthroat Technopaths were imprisoned there, often in fullbody restraints to limit their movement. These Technopaths were often ex-military, professional pirates, and wealthy gang members. They could afford top-of-the-line body mods. They had access to pocket dimensions and all sorts of other high technology. These mods were buried so deeply in their bodies that extracting them would kill the Technopaths, so those mods could only be disabled; not removed entirely. In theory, the High Security wing could even imprison low-level Psions, but nobody wanted to stress-test that assumption.

Thus, when the three newcomers arrived, they were scared senseless. Or at least Muuxunuu and Randis were. Unarin was at death's door. Its body was in terrible condition. With a severe head wound, it was likely to have suffered internal bleeding.

Luckily, Technopath doctors were miracle workers. The Commander chuckled when he saw Unarin being carted off to the surgery ward on arrival.

"Stupid. There's no point in fixing that bastard. You two, throw the pink and black one in minimum. Once that red one's all healed up, put it in maximum security. Any available cell will do!"

Lieutenant Trivald looked at Korvald in surprise. "But sir, the red one's crime doesn't nearly meet the level of maximum. If we put the Changeling in there, it will probably end up..."

Kordal frowned. He leaned toward Trivald and lowered his voice. "That's the *point*, nitwit. You've gotta keep these shitlings in line. Otherwise, they might resist orders more often, and then it becomes a *hassle*. Better to show them we mean business. Besides, this 'Unarin' isn't anyone important. It left the homeworld with no notable merits to its name. It has no base of support. Better to turn it into a warning for the others. Once its two

friends get out, they'll spread the word, and other Changelings will lower their heads to us out of fear."

The Commander pulled away, then patted his Lieutenant's back. "You see how it all fits together? Gotta keep 'em scared. That way it's nice and easy to push them around while we hunt down the real players in the game."

As the two Technopath Enforcers walked away, Trivald looked at his boss. "By the way, did you hear about the Thumper Gang? Seems someone cut them apart last night."

"That's the life of a thug. You always die eventually." Kordal chuckled.

After the two of them left, Unarin was placed inside a healing chamber. A flood of nutrient-rich medical liquid revitalized the red Changeling's injuries and restored clarity to its mind. Then, when Unarin awoke, it was shipped down to the maximum security level, where the most vicious and vile criminals were left to rot.

As Unarin walked between a pair of prison guards, its expression became somewhat wary. No matter how emotionless Unarin acted, the truth was, it knew it would die at some point in the near future. The Technopaths inside these cells might have their movements restricted, but once everyone was let out for light exercise, someone would be sure to kill Unarin just for existing and being weak.

"This is your cell, Inmate C-1175. You'd better remember it. Free roam time is 1200. That time ends at 1300. If you're not back in your cell by then, you will suffer full consequences."

Unarin's heart clamped up when the Changeling arrived in front of a cell which opened up to reveal a vicious-looking Technopath inside. Before Unarin could even get a good look at its cell-mate, it was pushed inside, and the door closed behind it.

The guards did not even bother to introduce Unarin to its cell-mate. There was no point. Unarin was certain to be dead within a few standard time-units... assuming its cell-mate didn't want to play with its food.

Unarin was put in high security to *die*. There was no other reason behind its imprisonment. Even an idiot could tell that much.

Standing there, in the cell, Unarin's gaze fell on the Technopath in the room. He was an ugly fellow. Withered, yellow skin. Rotted pustules covered his body's surface. It was evident he had been in the prison a long, long time. Perhaps for ten or more orbits...

The Technopath looked at Unarin. He spread his mouth open in a facsimile of a smile, but his face was truly disgusting. His teeth were all rotted and sticking out in different directions. His eyes were haggard.

Unarin blinked. When looking at this Technopath, somehow, Unarin did not feel fear. Instead, it felt... pity.

"I am Unarin." Unarin said calmly. "What name may I address you by, cell-mate?"

"Haaah..." The Technopath wheezed, coughing weakly. "What use is there in names? You know you're dead, yes? I won't hurt you, Changeling. Don't worry. But the others will. They will kill you... like they did the ones before you. Like they do all my cellmates... haaaah..."

The Technopath's eyes filled with tears of pain, and he coughed quietly several times. Unarin could tell at a glance that the Technopath suffered from a terrible respiratory infection.

"All the same, even if our time together is short, I would prefer not to refer to you as 'you'." Unarin said. The Changeling walked over and sat on the ground, its back against the wall, looking up at the mottled yellow Technopath.

"I was somebody important, once." The Technopath coughed. "I had a name. Status. Power. But that was so, so long ago. Now I have nothing. They imprisoned me for speaking my mind. They're scared, you know. Scared that someone might get a good idea."

The Technopath coughed again.

"Unarin. Let me give you a piece of advice. If you want to make enemies... try to change something."

"What did you try to change?" Unarin asked.

The Technopath chuckled. "I saw things. Things that would someday come to pass. They called me a lunatic. A madman. They sentenced me to rot down here until there was nothing left of me. But I know what I saw. I know *who* I saw. If those things came to pass, it would mean the end of the current Order. And that scared a lot of people. Scared them enough to want me *gone*."

The Technopath looked at Unarin sitting on the ground. He smiled, revealing his crooked, rotten teeth.

"My name is Vedric. Former Vizier of Father Zaeed's Temple."

"Vedric." Unarin repeated, bowing its head and pressing its palms together in greeting. "Whether we are friends for a time unit or an eternity, that does not matter. I only hope we will end our lives still as friends."

"Well said." Vedric said, his tone gentle. "I think I might even end up liking you."

Part 729: Unjustly Imprisoned

Reldis-02. South-side Prison, Maximum Security Wing. Stardate 207.715 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

Unarin and Vedric sat across from one another, the Changeling on the floor, and the withered Technopath on the lower bunkbed. Vedric shook his head in resignation.

"It's such a shame the prison wardens want you dead. That's why they put you down here. They know you won't last long. For some reason, they probably expected me to be the one to kill you. Just goes to show how little attention they pay toward the maximum security wing. They don't even remember who I am anymore."

"You were the former Vizier of Father Zaeed's Temple." Unarin said, repeating what Vedric had told him not too long before. "How could anyone forget your identity?"

"I have been in this prison for... perhaps thirty orbits." Vedric said, his eyes wistful. "Most of the guards here now are young replacements for the ones who originally were a part of this prison when I entered. They just see me as the same criminal filth as all the others down here. It is to be expected. My glory days are long past."

"Father Zaeed was the First Volgrim." Unarin said, touching its chin thoughtfully. "The first Dolgrimite to crawl out of the primordial muck and establish the Vol-Laws that would define our people for generations to come. How could someone like you, one of his most loyal adherents, have been cast down from such a high position?"

Vedric chuckled. "Remember what I told you, Unarin? I wanted to change things. This Empire is rotten. It has fallen far from the glory days of our ancestors. The four species are constantly at war. Even if the Dolgrimites keep to themselves now, they would gladly rip apart their brothers and sisters among the Psions, the Technopaths, and the Changelings if we were to step foot on their world. And now? The Technopaths trod upon the Changelings as if you were garbage that had little to offer in value. This, in spite of your great, great additions to the scientific annals."

The old Technopath cleared his throat, which also forced out a wheezy, rasping cough. "*Haaah, kuh-kuh*. When I was in the temple, I chanced upon a discovery that shook my beliefs to their core. It was a heretical discovery I should have cast aside, but the realization was too shocking for me to ignore. Once I had seen the light, I had to

investigate further. That investigation brought me into conflict with the Patriarchs and Matriarchs. They sentenced me to die of old age, imprisoned here for the rest of my life."

"What discovery was it?" Unarin asked, more curious than he had been about anything else in recent cycles. "What could you have uncovered that would make it worth throwing your life away?"

Vedric gave the young Changeling a long, hard look.

"There comes a time in many Volgrim's lives when they uncover a Truth so shocking that it threatens to upend their entire worldview. It was brought to my attention that the biology of the four species was... *flawed*. And not just a little flawed. Flawed in a way that seemed almost... *deliberate*."

Unarin was surprised. Had he not just been talking about something similar only the rotation before?

"You are referring to the way each species is missing 'something'?" Unarin asked. "Something that the other species possess?"

Vedric's eyes widened. He looked at Unarin in astonishment. "Well- well yes! Exactly! How did you guess? I've mentioned it to many cell-mates in the past, but few of them understood even when I explained it, and certainly none beat me to the punch like you just did!"

"Mmm. I have had my own doubts." Unarin said, shaking its head quietly.

"I see." Vedric replied, sobering up his expression. "Yes. Each of the four species is missing a component of themselves. The Dolgrimites are feral and savage, lacking in intelligence and curiosity. The Psions are powerful and mighty, but lacking in compassion and empathy. The Technopaths are wise and technologically advanced, but lacking in breadth and love for their own bodies. The Changelings are intelligent and thoughtful, but lacking in individuality and bodily strength."

He continued. "Each of the four species suffers from terrible flaws that hold them back. But what my source informed me of was the possibility that these flaws... might be *intentional*."

"Intentional?" Unarin repeated. "In what way? Are you implying the species have been tampered with? Who would even have the capability?"

"I do not know." Vedric said quietly. "Someone with great power and influence. Someone ancient, perhaps even ageless. Maybe they died long ago, or maybe they still live to this day. Whoever they are, the evidence I found was compelling. It seemed that our very DNA was altered at some point in our evolutionary past. The Psions, Technopaths, and Changelings did not naturally evolve from the Dolgrimites. We were forcibly split from them!"

This elicited a gasp of shock from Unarin. The Changeling could not believe its ears. "Are you saying three of the sub-species are artificially made?"

"No." Vedric said. "I'm telling you *all* of them are. It is quite likely the Dolgrimites themselves did not arise via natural evolutionary means. Someone *made them*. For what purpose? I do not know. Perhaps some ancient god. Perhaps an alien species residing elsewhere within our galaxy we have not yet met. Or... perhaps we *have*. The thought frightens me. It is entirely possible the Ruling Council of Volgrim might already be under this potential adversary's grip..."

Unarin nodded. The revelations were startling, yet for some reason, they weren't entirely *surprising*. Unarin felt as if it had already known some, or perhaps many of these things for a long time.

"Who was your source?" Unarin eventually asked.

Vedric hesitated. But then, remembering that Unarin was probably going to die soon, he sighed and shook his head. "It doesn't matter if I tell you or not. The person who informed me of this Truth was actually a Changeling. It came to my temple filled with doubts regarding a discovery it had made while studying the genetic sequences of all four species. Together, we investigated the missing links, and later, I lost touch with it. I have always wondered why..."

"Hmm. Come to think of it..." Vedric said, looking at Unarin a little more closely. "That Changeling looked a bit like you. It also had bright red skin. But ah, I am getting ahead of myself. What was its name again...? Hmm... perhaps..."

A few moments passed. The spark of memory entered old Vedric's eyes.

"Nurima! Yes, that was the Changeling's name."

A silence fell over the cell. Unarin looked at Vedric with disbelief in its eyes.

"Nurima? You said its name was Nurima? But... that was the name of my Progenitor!"

"What?!" Vedric exclaimed, even more shocked than Unarin was. "You... you are the progeny of Nurima?! How is such a coincidence possible? Why did you not recognize me immediately if that were the case?"

Unarin lowered its eyes bitterly. "I am sorry to inform you of this, Vedric. My Progenitor was attacked some twenty-eight orbits ago. It was on the verge of death and had to force a premature Osmosis to form me. It perished from its injuries not three rotations later. I was unable to complete the Genetic Transference. As a result, I have lived as a Featureless One my entire life, lacking all of my Progenitor's memories."

"So that's it... that is why." Vedric said, as he reached out a withered arm, his tendrils gently touching Unarin's shoulder. "I am so sorry, child. Your Progenitor was a genius. Now that I look at you, I see Nurima's shadow in you. You have the same doubts as they once did. You even speak in the same way they did. But alas... you have ended up here, trapped with me. It seems in the end, I will die along with my friend... and their memories."

Unarin scowled angrily. "To think this is why I have lived my life so aimlessly. My Progenitor was murdered because it knew information that threatened the Order! They must have left me alone because I was a Featureless One and could not pass on my knowledge. But now that they have a chance, they're going to eliminate me!"

"That is likely the truth." Vedric replied, pulling his arm away from Unarin's shoulder. "But... you know, I am not ignorant in the ways of Genetic Transference. Before you die, it might be possible to let you regain those memories you lost."

"What is the point now?" Unarin asked, a mixture of bitterness and helplessness in the Changeling's voice. "I am going to die. Even with the memories, what can I accomplish?"

Vedric's expression hardened. "Speak NOT such words! Haaaah! *Kuh-kuh!* As long as you are alive, there is still hope. There is always hope! Why do you think the Order wants you gone? If news of this got out, it could destabilize their regime! There is nothing they fear more than being pulled from their towers and cast out onto the streets. Besides, the maximum security wing was not designed for Changelings. Look at how wide the bars are! Perhaps you might be able to slip out..."

Unarin looked at the prison cell. Truly, they did seem just barely wide enough that if the Changeling were to shift its body composition...

"You see?!" Vedric exclaimed. "Don't give up hope, child. Never give up. Why do you think I am still alive? I held on because I believed I might be the last person possessing the knowledge I do now. If I remained alive, a day might come where I could escape and spread this information around. Then my life would not be in vain!"

Unarin lowered its head. "I apologize, Vedric. I was not thinking clearly. You are right. Where there is life, there is hope. Please. If you have a way to help me regain my lost memories, I would much appreciate the help."

Vedric smiled. "This old Volgrim was once head of a church that saw millions of adherents from all the species pass through its doors to pay their respects to Father Zaeed. Naturally, I made friends with many Changelings and learned of many secrets. The process of Memory Transference without a Progenitor present is quite ordinary, as the memories are already within you! Come, sit beside me."

Unarin nodded. The Changeling got up, took a few steps forward, and sat beside Vedric. The old Technopath carefully placed two tendrils on the sides of Unarin's head, and two more on the Changeling's forehead and the back of its head.

"Now, listen carefully, child. Close your eyes. Focus your mind. Within you, there is an abyss. That abyss is an illusion. Within the illusion- HMM?!"

Vedric jumped slightly. His eyes widened in shock, which in turn startled Unarin.

"What? What is the matter?" Unarin asked, slightly nervous. "Is something wrong?"

"Wrong? Wrong?! By no means! Incredible! I cannot believe it! This explains so much! Now I understand why Nurima was so far above its peers! It seems your Progenitor unlocked its Mind Realm, and before passing away, it passed that Mind Realm on to you! This- I have not seem something like this before. Just how advanced was Nurima's knowledge of Volgrim biology?"

"What is a Mind Realm?" Unarin asked.

"Hehe, child, you are going to be pleasantly surprised. Mind Realms are extremely rare metaphysical abilities that few Volgrim can obtain. Psions possess the majority of them, and even among High Psions they are quite rare! They allow you to build a miniaturized world within your mind, one in which you have full control over the rules. Most amazingly, yours is fully developed! All of your Progenitor's knowledge is still in there!!"

Vedric was growing visibly more excited. His eyes turned feral, and a hateful gleam entered his eyes.

"Die? No, I will **not** let Nurima's progeny die here. I'll do anything it takes to get you out, even if I have to futilely fight my way out of this cell protecting you, hahaha! Now, now, let's calm down. This Mind Realm won't matter if I don't unlock the Ancestral Memories for you. Remember, child, these are not just Nurima's memories, but the memories of its predecessors as well. Passed down, one generation after another, these memories are what grant the Changelings their unique biological advantage. Without them, you have been living among the others of your kind as a crippled Volgrim; one missing half its limbs. These memories are sure to make you much more fearsome than you can imagine!"

And so, the two Volgrim began to focus. Vedric carefully guided Unarin through its doubts, and time began to pass.

One time unit became two, and two became fifteen, then thirty...

Eventually, an entire five standard time-units had passed. Vedric was starting to sweat, because while it was somewhat early in the morning, it would be Free Roam time soon. That was when Unarin would be forced out into the open area along with all the battle hardened Psion murderers and criminals. They would surely rip the Changeling apart the moment they laid eyes on him!

Unarin's eyes became glazed. Before long, the Changeling began to drift off.

Recommended Listening

The world disappeared around Unarin. A new one appeared.

Unarin opened its eyes. Before it, there was now a tall, glittering city, a city made of buildings so large they scraped the stratosphere. The Changeling had never seen a land as advanced as this. Each building was ugly, but utilitarian. The towers rose so high that Unarin could not even come close to seeing their heights from the ground level.

Strange flying vehicles, more advanced than any which currently existed among the Volgrim, buzzed through the air by the hundreds of thousands. The sky itself seemed to be moving, like a swarm of bugs, as endless as an ocean.

A moment later, the city disappeared. Unarin found itself now in a realm of darkness, one where horrifying shadow-monsters slowly walked toward the Changeling. Their eyes were filled with naked hunger. They greedily looked upon the Changeling as a morsel they wished to devour.

"**Consume.**" A ominous, evil voice boomed from the distance. Unarin's eyes went wide with fear as the barely visible monsters leaped at the Changeling.

Before they could make contact, they disappeared as well.

Following this, Unarin found itself inside a realm of white light. All around the Changeling, there were bipedal winged beings bowing toward a being hovering high in the sky. That being was shrouded by a brilliant light which made it impossible for Unarin to perceive. All Unarin could make out were the backsides of these white-feathered, flying beings.

"Hail the Ruler! Hail the god of the Milky Way!" The army of light bellowed!

That vision vanished. In its place, a single figure appeared. It was a Changeling, red in color, laying on a bed inside a hospital room. The Changeling looked similar to Unarin... but much older.

"Progenitor... Nurima..." Unarin whispered, taking a step toward the figure it recognized immediately.

Unarin fought back tears. Never did the Changeling expect it would see its Progenitor again in this life. And yet, the sight was so tragic, so sad, seeing it weak and defenseless like this...

"Progeny..." Nurima said, its voice weak. "You have... finally... unlocked your memories. Long have I awaited your arrival. What you see now is only a sliver of my remaining existence."

Nurima shuddered. Its body grew slightly more hazy.

"I have... held on... for many orbits. But I was near death when I passed my Mind Realm on to you. Listen well... we do not have much time left together."

Unarin walked to the side of the bed. It knelt beside its Progenitor and gently clasped their palms together.

"Speak, Progenitor. I will listen." Unarin vowed.

Nurima coughed. "Good... *cough*! I... was... part of a long lineage of Changelings. I... was part of a secret Order. The others are all dead. We were... wiped out... by the ruling Volgrim. They did not know of my Mind Realm. If they had, you would have been exterminated too. We learned the Truth... the Truth, Unarin. Our four species are all artificial."

"I know, Progenitor." Unarin said. "I have spoken to Vedric. He has told me everything he knew."

"Vedric...?" Nurima asked, a rare smile playing upon its face. "Oh... Vedric... he still lives. Good. That is good. Vedric was one of the few who would listen. He is an ally you can trust. If he has helped you, then I am truly gladdened. Listen, Unarin... there is something that not even Vedric knows."

Nurima gritted their teeth. The Changeling leaned toward Unarin.

"I solved it. The secret of our failed biology. Haha... I planned... to use this knowledge... but I was too old. My body was too weak. And then the assassination attempt. I had no choice. I passed my Truth onto you. Now, you have the knowledge. You can solve the paradox of our people. Unarin, you are the last member of the Order of Ascension. Only you can do what we could not. I know my request is selfish... but so long as you succeed, you can undermine the *evil one* who has secretly played our people for fools! Only you possess the power..."

Nurima's body faded a little more. Without hesitation, it lifted its hand, then reached up and pointed at the center of Unarin's forehead.

"Go, child. Take this knowledge. With your strong, youthful body... *ascend*. You will be the First. You will solve the problems that plagued our people. You will gain the power to fight back against that *evil one*... because if you fail, I fear that our people will not have much longer left to live."

Nurima's finger began to glow with light. When it touched Unarin's brow, the younger Changeling shuddered.

The Mind Realm began to change, shift and distort.

Nurima smiled... one last time.

"You bear... all our hopes and dreams... child. Become the Volgrim I never could... farewell..."

Unarin's mouth opened, and a beam of light shot out.

All at once, every part of the Mind Realm turned a brilliant white.

Unarin could see everything.

The genetic sequences of millions, even billions of Volgrim, from all four subspecies.

The missing links. The gaps. The suspicious points of failure that could not have occurred naturally.

No, they weren't just suspicious. They were malicious!

Someone had placed them there. Someone with evil intentions. Someone who had made the Volgrim to be a living, biological weapon.

This revelation enraged Unarin. The Changeling became so incensed that its anger threatened to explode and consume its own body in hatred.

"WHO..." Unarin roared in his mind. "**DARES?!**"

Unarin reached out. Its hands began to move like lightning as it rapidly grabbed hold of the genetic sequences and began rearranging them at a speed beyond what any mortal could accomplish.

Unarin ripped apart chunks from one strand of DNA, then shoved them into another. The young Changeling's mind moved with a speed and ferocity fueled by righteous rage.

The Truth was here. Anyone with a brain could see it... but the Truth had been suppressed. Unarin's Progenitor had even been killed to hide the evidence!

Eventually, Unarin finished re-sequencing the entire genetic sequence.

He became Enlightened.

At that moment, *He* Ascended.

Part 730: ASCENDED

Reldis-02. South-side Prison, Maximum Security Wing. Stardate 207.715 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

Something indescribable happened as Unarin's entire psyche underwent a change. His core being merged with the Mind Realm passed down to him by his predecessors. His body began to glow with light. His very genetic structure itself rapidly began to change.

Somewhere between one second and a hundred years passed in a single instant. Unarin's eyes flashed open, and he awoke.

He found himself in a strange world. It was a land filled with divine light, a sky shrouded with clouds, and trees sparsely populating a lush and grassy plain covered by flowers.

The trees were not ordinary trees. At a glance, Unarin could easily see that they had differently colored gems growing from them. The trees themselves seemed to be made of diamond, while their 'fruits' were rubies, sapphires, onyxes, and countless other types that would usually only be found deep underground.

Unarin took a step forward. He was confused. He didn't know where he had arrived, or how he had ended up there. But that single step made him pause and look down.

Unarin felt different.

He was different.

"My... body..." Unarin said, startled by the deepness in his voice. He held up his hands, and his eyes went wide. They were bigger now, with three fingers and a thumb. His arms were extremely muscular, and so was his now-nude lower body. Unarin barely looked at himself for even a few moments before he began to feel dizzy from what he was seeing.

His body had changed. Drastically. He didn't recognize what he saw.

And then there was that word. 'He'.

Unarin felt that he was a he now. He was not genderless. And this was confirmed by the appendage dangling between his legs. Only after he saw it did the pieces start to fall into place.

Tears welled up in Unarin's eyes.

"Progenitor... I... succeeded." Unarin whispered.

Ten thousand orbits had passed since the Order of Ascension came into being. Countless Changelings had died, passing on knowledge from one generation to the next as they pursued the Truth of their species. Now, Unarin had reaped the rewards, but at a terrible cost to those who came before him.

His body was no longer the frail, weak, pathetic thing that it once was. He had three toes that faced forward, with claws that stuck out and gripped the ground, as well as a reverse 'toe' on his heel. Eight long tendrils flowed from the back of his head like hair and draped over and behind his shoulders, reaching down to his waist.

"Haa'ti..." Unarin said slowly, as he lifted the nearest one and touched it. A moment later, a strange sensation swept through his body. Unarin nearly fell to his knees, opting instead to stagger weakly and groan in pleasure.

The Haa'ti were extremely sensitive. Each tendril was something of an erogenous zone, and simply touching them made Unarin experience a sensation his mind had never once come into contact with in all his years of living as a Changeling.

Out of nowhere, a voice spoke from Unarin's right. "Having fun playing with yourself?"

Unarin's eyes widened. He spun on his heel-claw and looked at the one who had spoken. "Who's there! Who are you? *What* are... you...?"

There was a presumably male figure standing there, his body glowing with a brilliant light. The man's features were completely indistinguishable. He stood with a hand on his hip, perhaps fully nude, perhaps wearing clothing... Unarin could not tell. A single glance was all it took to determine the speaker was... someone extraordinary.

"I should be the one asking that question." The man said. "You are... out of my expectations. Are you a Volgrim? You don't look like the others I've seen. Ah, but where are my manners? I am the Creator. Former Ruler of the Milky Way."

Unarin blinked. "Ruler... you're a Ruler? *Our* Ruler?"

"Not *am*, *was*." The Creator corrected. "But then I died. What's left of me is... this. Not much to speak of. But enough about me. Let's talk about you. What are you? A mortal with no Cosmic power, yet you have somehow attained enlightenment? Not an impossible feat, but certainly rare."

Unarin squinted. "Enlightenment... I don't understand. Where am I? What's going on?"

And so, like that, the Creator gestured to a towering mountain behind him and explained the situation.

"So... this is what Psions see when they Ascend past the 5th Level of Psionics?" Unarin asked.

"Oh yes. In fact, people can Ascend multiple times. Everyone is guaranteed a first Ascension when they become a Cosmic, and after that, they have the chance to Ascend and climb these stairs again if they pass certain prerequisites. Merely becoming a stronger Cosmic won't do. You need to become more 'whole' in a way that, frankly, I don't think I could explain in a way you'd understand."

Unarin rubbed his chin. "I see. So then, I am..."

"Not a Cosmic!" The Creator said, visibly surprised. "I'd be lying if I said for every thousand Cosmics there was one mortal who gained Enlightenment. Maybe even ten thousand would be a bit off! You're only the third one in the entire Milky Way to do it so far!"

"Who were the previous two?" Unarin immediately asked.

The Creator shook his head. "Ask me again someday if you ever become a proper Cosmic. For now, I'll just have you climb a few steps and get this over with. Any mortal who can make it to the 5th step will obtain a mighty foundation, but if you can make it to the 10th step... you'll probably scare the life out of some of the other Rulers."

The Creator gestured, and Unarin followed as they approached the Staircase of Ascension.

"What's this about a 'foundation'?" Unarin asked as they approached the bottom step.

"Foundation is everything." The Creator explained. "Think of a weak Technopath versus a strong one. The weak one has shoddy body-mods. They are weak and frail. The strong one is strong because their body's foundation is better. This is true at all levels of power, even among Cosmics. A 7th Level Psion with a shoddy foundation will not be nearly as powerful as one with a robust foundation. And one with a robust foundation can put up a fight against a weak 8th Level Psion."

"I understand, but I still don't understand what a foundation *is*." Unarin replied. "This staircase improves my foundation, right? That is what you said."

"The Staircase of Ascension is a test, and a boon. In order to climb these steps, willpower, purity, and a strong heart are most important. The strength of your body, less so." The Creator explained. "That is the reason why every so often, a single mortal can arrive here. You are not yet a Cosmic, but you have obtained enlightenment. Your mind and soul are much sturdier than other mortals. You likely have some impressive level of willpower, as well. Conversely, it's not too rare to see some pathetic excuse for a Cosmic stumble in here, having taken vicious and evil shortcuts to empower themselves. It's entirely possible a powerful mortal like you could climb more steps than them."

The Creator paused.

"But, just to be clear, the strongest mortal is little more than an ant before the weakest Cosmic. If you fought a Bottom Cosmic, you would die. Your Foundation is most important for paving the path to your own Cosmic superiority someday. That way, when you truly Ascend, instead of climbing a mere five or ten steps, you could climb hundreds, perhaps even thousands!"

"And climbing more steps is not only a test of my willpower, but it strengthens me as well." Unarin summarized. "In that case, I should endeavor to climb as many steps as possible."

"That's the spirit." The Creator said with a smile. "Every step you take, divine lightning will fall and strike your body. It will be extremely painful, especially because you are a mere mortal. Even so, the lightning cannot kill you. It will only bring you to your limit and eventually immobilize you, preventing you from climbing even higher. No matter how much it hurts, you must press on until your body refuses to move. The higher you climb, the more robust your foundation, and the greater your strength when you return to reality."

Unarin nodded. The Creator had already explained to him that this was an independent space from reality, and time was frozen in the outside world until Unarin reached the end of his time here.

"Then there's nothing more to speak of." Unarin said, his tone calm and placid. "I am an Ascended... so I must Ascend."

The Creator snorted. "You kids always title yourselves so arrogantly. Just don't go off creating a 'Cosmic Realm' of your own. It was embarrassing enough the first time one of you did that."

Recommended Listening

Unarin took his first step. Immediately a bolt of lightning fell from above and struck his body.

As soon as his foot made contact with the Staircase of Ascension, a few nearby Rulers happened to glance over. One of them was a bipedal figure, black in color, with feathered wings and blood-red eyes full of malice.

"Heheh, looks like the Creator has another climber. And what's this? A mere mortal? What a rarity. Let's go have a laugh at his expense."

Two other Rulers, mere orbs of light, levitated beside the Dark One.

[It is a species we have not seen before. Worth investigation.] Triangulum's Ruler, The Absolute stated.

[The appearance of the inferior biological is interesting. Its design is unlike any others.] Cartwheel's Ruler, Guide, added.

The three Rulers flew closer. They watched as the strange new biological creature took its first step upon the Staircase.

When the lightning bolt fell, the Dark One smiled. He waited for the first scream of agony to escape the creature's lips.

Instead, Unarin paused, cocked his head, then took another step.

"Hmm? No reaction?" The Dark One murmured. "Odd."

When Unarin took the second step and another bolt of lightning fell, he looked directly up at it, and it struck his body with thunderous force.

BOOOM!

But Unarin... felt nothing.

The Creator watched from the side, looking uneasy. "If it hurts, you can just shout out. No need to hold the pain in, kid."

"I will keep that in mind." Unarin said.

And so, he took a third step. Then a fourth.

Lightning struck him. The Cosmic Realm shuddered.

But Unarin felt nothing.

Well, that wasn't to say *nothing*. He felt as if someone had poked him in the back. It barely felt like much. Certainly not the soul-wracking pain he had expected.

"Hmm..." Unarin hummed.

The Dark One's eyes flashed. "What is this mortal creature? There's no way it would simply be pretending to feel nothing. Perhaps it has a strong ego that prevents it from shouting out."

[Four steps is a good height for any mortal to climb.] The Absolute said. [Its strength meets the level of satisfactory.]

But then Unarin climbed the fifth step.

And the sixth.

And the seventh...

The Creator started to frown. "Unarin... are you alright?"

"I'm fine." Unarin said, his tone as mild as ever. "This lightning is certainly loud, but... I don't feel anything. Is that normal?"

"Nothing?" The Creator repeated. "Nothing at all?"

Unarin shrugged. "Nothing to speak of. If you don't mind, I'm going to climb a little faster, since my time here is limited and all..."

And so, Unarin did something none of the Rulers watching expected a mere mortal to do in a million Eternities. He began to lightly jog up the steps.

The Dark One's eyes went wide as Unarin suddenly leaped up the 8th, 9th, and 10th step in quick succession without pausing.

"What?!"

His shout of shock traveled throughout the Cosmic Realm. At once, dozens of other Rulers turned their attention toward the Milky Way's Staircase of Ascension. The tone

used by the Dark One was highly irregular. It indicated something out of the ordinary was happening.

Unarin continued to climb. He reached the 12th step. Then the 15th. Then the 20th...

Every time the lightning struck him, Unarin felt nothing. It was like a single drop of water hitting the top of his head. If multiple lightning strikes weren't hitting him one after the other, he might miss them entirely.

Ten Rulers came to watch Unarin's climb. Then ten became twenty. Fifty, a hundred...

Soon, a massive swarm of orbs of light began to conglomerate around the Milky Way's staircase. The Creator was shocked out of his wits. It wasn't that climbing twenty steps was impressive... any Cosmic could do it.

But a mortal?

A mere mortal?!

It was damn near unheard of! The Creator had lived through a handful of Eternities, and across all that time, he had not seen it once!

Unarin climbed faster and faster. He made it to thirty steps, then forty...

By now, everyone watching had realized something unbelievable was going on. This wasn't just an outlier, it should have been impossible!

"Kee-keep going!" The Creator stuttered. "Unarin, if you can make it to a hundred steps, the First Ruler, Akasha, will grant you a powerful boon! If you make it to 250 steps, or 500, or 1000, he'll give even more boons! Keep climbing, kid!"

Unarin nodded, not even slowing his pace. He continued racing upward, while even more and more Rulers arrived to look upon him with shock and disbelief.

The Dark One gnashed his teeth. His eyes became bloodshot as he looked upon the Milky Way's newest glory child with hate-filled eyes. "How?! How could that incompetent Creator have formed such an amazing life-form?! It's impossible!!"

Unarin had no idea what was going on. He had only heard the faintest rumors of 'ascensions' from Changelings who monitored the Psions. He never had any details, so he didn't know how frightening his climb was to those watching him. In fact, he had no idea that his climb was the most unique thing any Ruler present had seen since the birth and death of multiple past universes!

He just kept climbing. Each step he took, he could feel a light pressure building in his chest. Whether it was exhaustion from climbing the Staircase of Ascension, or whether it was exhilaration from being watched by so many powerful entities, he could not tell.

Unarin climbed and climbed, and climbed some more.

To the horror and shock of many, he raced past the 100th step, causing shouts to erupt among the watching Rulers.

"Incredible!" A quadrupedal Ruler from a distant galaxy shouted. "It has been one hundred and ninety Eternities since a mortal climbed this far! And look, he doesn't seem to be slowing down!"

110 steps. 120. 150...

Unarin's speed continued to increase. He sprinted up the steps, each bolt of lightning splashing harmlessly against his face as if they meant nothing at all!

Before long, Unarin reached the 200th step. The Dark One's face had gone pale with fear. If a mere mortal could climb this high, that meant he was a Candidate of extreme potential. He was sure to become the Milky Way's next Ruler. And this power he was displaying now would become tens, even hundreds of times greater once he became a Cosmic. However high he climbed now, his foundation would become so terrifying that he might jump straight to the thousandth step upon his Cosmic ascension in a single bound!

Who knew the heights this creature would rise to?!

"We have to assassinate it.." The Dark One hissed through his teeth. "We cannot allow it to grow. It will become a terrifying Ruler, way more fearsome than the Creator ever was! We have to kill it before it truly Ascends... but how? The Akashic Barriers will not drop for a long, long time..."

After reaching the 200th step, Unarin paused, then he continued to climb.

But now, his steps were beginning to slow. Unarin's breath became noticeably more pained.

He reached the 210th step, then he paused for a few moments before climbing again.

He reached the 215th step, then wiped sweat from his brow.

By the time he reached the 220th step, Unarin had dramatically slowed down his pace. He clutched his chest and wheezed as if he were going to suffer a heart attack.

The Creator frowned. He flew a little closer.

"Are you growing tired, Unarin?"

"Not... not tired." Unarin wheezed. "There's a pressure in my chest. I think it's my heart. It's getting really hard to climb. I'm still going to push further though. You said the pain can't kill me, right?"

The Creator looked at Unarin thoughtfully. He flew next to Unarin, then touched the Volgrim's chest before abruptly retracting his hand.

"I... I can't believe it. You absolute monster." The Creator growled. "I cannot remember this ever happening to anyone from my galaxy, but I've seen it happen elsewhere. Your mind and willpower are more than capable of climbing far higher. But, unfortunately, your body has hit its limit. Your foundation is about to burst."

"Burst?" Unarin asked.

"You're not a proper Cosmic. It is a miracle you have climbed this far. Mortals simply should not be able to do what you've done. Rest assured, you are the mightiest mortal in the entire universe. *Without a doubt*. You even have the strength to battle real Cosmics, but without the baggage of the Akashic Laws. Never mind, that's not important. Forget what I said earlier. If you climb much further, you will die."

Unarin looked at him in disbelief. "But you said-"

"What I told you was that the pain from the lightning couldn't kill you, and it can't." The Creator said, shaking his head. "But this is different. You're like a bottle being overfilled with water. A full bottle is a good thing. But one filled past its limit will shatter into a thousand pieces. That will be your fate."

The Creator squeezed Unarin's arm reassuringly.

"The next time you come here, you will be a Cosmic. And seeing how formidable your mind is now, I believe you will crush the records of countless others who came before you. But that day is not now. Do not throw your life away in order to sate your ego."

Unarin looked at the Creator. The Ruler of the Milky Way had shown to have Unarin's best interests in heart this whole time, so he could not disregard his Ruler's words.

Unarin's shoulders relaxed. He looked up the steps toward the distant 250th step. If he could have reached it, he could have obtained a second boon. But based on what the

Creator said, it was nearly impossible for mere mortals to even obtain the first boon, and Unarin had done so handily.

He was more than satisfied with his efforts.

"Very well. Then I shall stop here." Unarin said, turning to look up at the army of Rulers watching him from on high. Mixed with the lights of countless Evolved were a small smattering of former-biological Rulers, similar to the Creator. They were outnumbered fifty to one by the Evolved.

It was truly, truly difficult for a biological entity to take control of a galaxy...

After Unarin gracefully conceded, a powerful wind fell downward from the top of the stairs. A godlike figure descended from on high. It appeared to be a giant turtle, levitating in the air through some unknown means, its entire body made of black obsidian except for its red eyes.

"The 411th Envoy of Akasha!" The Creator exclaimed, quickly bowing his head in respect. "Envoy Akupara. We are humbled by your appearance."

All the Rulers shivered and bowed. It was highly unusual for such a high-level Envoy to descend and grant a reward. The closer to the first position that they were ranked, the older and more respected they were, as well as the more powerful.

"**Milky Way Ascender.**" Akupara said, its tone polite, subdued, yet equally authoritative. "**You are the most impressive mortal seen in 1,713 Eternities. Not since the legend of Agvar the Unstoppable has such a mortal been seen. You are worthy of a powerful boon. Speak your name, title, and request. Akasha shall grant it if he sees fit.**"

Unarin, naturally bowed his head and clasped his hands before the presence of the awe-inspiring Envoy of Akasha. Even though it was a flying turtle, which seemed somewhat absurd, Unarin was certainly broad-minded enough to overlook this fact.

"Envoy Akupara. This small mortal has but one request. If possible, I wish to be able to spread my power far and wide. Naturally, only to those who are worthy."

The turtle tilted its head slightly. "**Your request is not for personal empowerment, but the empowerment of others? Are you certain?**"

Unarin nodded without looking up. "Yes, Envoy."

The turtle closed its eyes and audibly *hummed*, a deep vibration that made the souls of all present quake powerlessly.

"**Hummm…. I see. I shall pass that request on.**"

A moment passed. Akupara looked upward for several long seconds, toward the unseen top of the staircase, shrouded by the clouds.

Then, he lowered his gaze back to the mortal life form bowing before him.

"**Your request amuses Akasha. He is interested in seeing what sort of havoc you will unleash.**" Akupara said meaningfully. "**This power he is granting you will be mighty indeed… but it will not be without flaws. Choose whom you offer the Test of Ascension to with great care.**"

"I will, Envoy Akupara." Unarin said. He slapped his hand over his heart and looked up at the Envoy with eyes full of vigor. "Give my thanks to the One On High!"

"**Nothing transpires that He does not see.**" Akupara said, before flying back up into the sky. Once he passed through the cloud cover, he vanished from sight. Not even the Rulers were allowed to peer beyond the clouds shrouding the top of the Staircase.

After a long moment of silence, The Creator chuckled. "Oh, Unarin. You are quite crafty. That request was beyond what I had expected. Simple, yet… effective."

The Creator secretly looked over at the Dark One. His face was ashen, knowing that soon, the Milky Way would have even more of those horrifying *Ascended* running around. Now, assassinating Unarin was pointless. Another Ascended could rise up after him.

The Creator was *quite* pleased by this.

"You will now return from whence you came." The Creator said. "Remember. Among mortals, you are now an existence more terrifying than any others. But among Cosmics, you are but a speck of sand amidst a much larger and greater ocean. Until you rise to the rank of Cosmic yourself, do not become complacent. Continue to grow until you have become undefeatable. Only then will I be able to pass the rule of this galaxy down to you without worries."

Unarin was surprised. "You believe I can rise to such a height?"

"If not you, then perhaps someone else." The Creator said cryptically. "But after today's show? You *are* my number one pick."

The Creator waved his hand. Light began to swallow Unarin, and his vision grew hazy.

"See you next time, kid." The Creator said, before bursting into laughter. "Oh, Dark One, you should see the look on your-"

His voice disappeared, and Unarin's soul fell down, down, down, back to the world of Reldis-02...

What happened next would mark the biggest change the Volgrim Empire had seen in tens of thousands of cycles...

Part 731: ABOMINATIONS

Reldis-02. South-side Prison, Maximum Security Wing. Stardate 207.715 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

Unarin's soul fell back into his body. The sense of enlightenment he had experienced inside the Cosmic Realm vanished, and he was once again back in the realm of mortals.

Unarin opened his eyes. He turned to his left, where he saw Vedric now standing up, his back flat against the wall as he looked at Unarin with a mixture of fear and shock.

"Y-you... you??" Vedric coughed.

Unarin blinked. He looked downward and saw that his body had changed. No longer was he a tall, gangly Changeling with skinny arms, slender legs, and a bit fat head. He was now extremely muscled, broad-shouldered, and had eight tendrils extending from the back of his skull down the front and real of his body.

They were his *Haa'ti*. The word came to his mind as easily as his own name. It was like he had been born with and lived his entire life with these strange tendrils. He knew them like the back of his hand.

Unarin slowly stood up. He smiled.

"Brother Vedric. I am still Unarin. You do not need to fear."

Vedric's pupils trembled. He looked at Unarin as if he were seeing a strange alien xenomorph for the first time. Parts of Unarin still looked 'Volgrim', but he was incomprehensibly different from his previous appearance.

"Una...rin... it's really... you?" Vedric whispered hesitantly. "You changed... instantly! There was a bright light, and..."

"I have become Ascended." Unarin said, his tone calm and collected. "I am a Changeling no more. I am a new species of Volgrim. I am the thing my progenitor sought. After all your troubles, I have finally eaten the fruits of your labor. You have my undying gratitude."

Vedric slowly pulled away from the wall. He stepped toward Unarin and relaxed. Even though Unarin's voice was different, he spoke the same was as before. Vedric was not so

closed-minded that he would remain in a state of fear and panic forever. He got over his confusion quickly, accepting this new reality with ease.

"Wonderful. Simply wonderful..." Vedric whispered. "Nurima... your life was not lost in vain. He has accomplished everything we hoped for. Now, I can die at peace."

Vedric lowered his eyes. He exhaled quietly, seeming more content than he ever had been at any point in the past.

But at that moment, Unarin reached out and gently clapped a hand on Vedric's shoulder.

"Vedric. You were my progenitor's brother. That makes you like an uncle to me. How could I let my uncle speak of dying when such a bright future stands before us now?"

Vedric looked up. He saw Unarin's beaming smile.

"Of course I will not die immediately. But my youth is gone, and I have few cycles remaining. Do not speak idle words just to cheer me up. The future belongs to the young."

Unarin's smile became gentler. "What if I told you there was a New Path you might be able to walk... if you had the courage to give it a try?"

"Courage?" Vedric repeated.

Unarin smiled but said nothing.

Vedric was enlightened. As he looked at Unarin's new body, he came to realize what this 'New Path' might entail.

"Lad." Vedric said, a smoldering fire emerging in his eyes. "If I can obtain a body such as yours... I would go to any length to bring down a righteous fire upon our corrupted overlords. What must I do?"

Unarin lifted his hand off Vedric's shoulder, then he extended his pointer finger toward Vedric's forehead.

"**BELIEVE.**"

* * *

Inside the prison's security office.

"It's almost Free Roam time." One of the Technopath guards said, a muscled fellow with military-grade augmentations that made him a walking fortress. "Fifteen more time-units."

Commander Kordal was there too. His plain grey skin and heavily augmented body made him not stick out much among other Technopaths, but now he was wearing a bright yellow uniform with blue stripes. This signified to the other officers that a commander was inside the prison, and they needed to be on alert in case he walked by. Nobody wanted to be caught goofing off.

"Feeling antsy?" Kordal taunted. "Relax. With the Thumpers running scared, we're not gonna bring in any fun ones for the new few rotations. The remaining gangs have lowered their heads and gotten all quiet. They'll be hard to sniff out. Won't leave us any openings."

Lieutenant Trivald was also there. He had a large stun gun strapped to his back, one that could fire out a devastatingly powerful bolt of electricity capable of knocking out just about any Volgrim who wasn't wearing a specialized anti-energy suit. It was especially effective against heavily-modded Technopaths, such as the street thugs they regularly crossed paths with.

"Commander, how many veds do you think we'll get for retrieving the Exigent-13?" Trivald asked.

Kordal thought about it for a moment. "Always with the money questions. Well, we only recovered two doses. Split between the whole group, we might all get... 1,750 veds? 2,000 at most."

Trivald's mouth-tendrils writhed in annoyance. "I told you we brought too many others with us."

"You did, but don't forget, the other officers deserve a reward once in a while. We can't just hog all the good stuff. It breeds disloyalty and backstabbers when you do that."

"That's a good point." Trivald said. He started to change the topic, but a light started blinking on the security system, and at that moment, all the cameras went down inside the maximum security wing.

"What the-?" Trivald gasped. "Why'd the feed go down? Get it back up!"

The monitoring security guard frowned. His fingers rapidly typed on the keyboards.

"There was some sort of an EMP pulse. One of the doors on the bottom level triggered a damage alarm. I'll pull up the last part of the feed."

He quickly rewound the camera, and everyone looked up at the security feed just in time to see a door suddenly blast outward and go flying off its hinges, slamming into the

opposite wall, as if it had been struck by something with violent force. Then the cameras went down immediately after that.

Kordal's eyes widened. "Red alert! We have a breakout attempt! All guards to maximum security! Full armaments, try to stun unless the subject presents a threat. Then shoot to kill!"

Kordal started to run out of the room, but the monitoring guard shouted something from behind him.

"Commander! The cell that sounded the alarm... it's Old Vedric's cell."

Kordal stumbled slightly, but he didn't bother responding as he ran out of the room.

In the back of his head, a thought bubbled up.

Wasn't that the one where we threw that yappy shitling?

Kordal and Trivald joined up with the initial reinforcements, and the two of them charged toward the lower levels as quickly as they could, hastily arming themselves and preparing to take down any prisoners who might have gotten a stupid idea in their heads.

When the first guards arrived inside the maximum security area, they were surprised to see that all of the lights had gone out. The pitch-black hallways yawned before them ominously, and the fervent shouting of inmates showed they had whipped themselves into a frenzy. All kinds of Technopath thugs, criminals, and general bastards were roaring and screaming like animals, grabbing and shaking their bars violently, all of which was a bit distracting for the guards.

Naturally, even if the lights were out, this wouldn't hurt the visibility of the guards too much. They activated their iris implants and swiveled their guns around, waiting for orders from their Commander.

The maximum security was shaped like a square. The path from the entrance split to the left and right, looped around, and connected at the opposite end. There was only one way up and down, ensuring any escape attempts would always end up funneled into a kill-zone, if things came to that.

"Split up!" Kordal shouted.

Trivald nodded. The two of them went left and right, with Kordal taking the shortest route toward Vedric's cell, which was down the left corridor, toward the end of the west

wing. Trivald swung around the backside, aiming to pincer any escapees if they thought they could be slick and get out through the other direction.

Boots struck the ground heavily. Trivald fearlessly led his strongest squad down the western corridor, their weapons held up and primed to shoot. Only Trivald himself was equipped with a lethal Tri-Gun, a weapon that had three different firing modes for taking down different enemies. The rest of his squad were armed with stun guns similar to the one Trivald wielded, albeit a little lighter, since only the Lieutenant was an elite with body mods able to heft such a formidable weapon.

"Shut up!" Kordal shouted at the prisoners as he ran past. The loudmouths screamed at him, jeered him, and shouted obscenities, only shrinking back and quieting down for a moment when one of the guard shone their flashlights on the inmates, making them step back and wince from the bright light.

It didn't take long. Kordal arrived at Vedric's cell first. He spin-stepped to face inside, but obviously, nobody was there.

"Vedric..." Kordal grunted. "Sly bastard. How long have you been planning- huh?"

Kordal glanced at the opposite wall. The cell door was stuck halfway inside the duracrete, and it looked like a toothpick that had been stuck inside a piece of cake. These doors, and the walls, were built to house Class V felons. They weren't indestructible, but Kordal knew there shouldn't be a Technopath down here with body mods capable of bending the bars, let along causing such a visibly violent level of damage.

His eyes twitched. "What in the damnation happened down here?"

Suddenly, there was a bloodcurdling scream further up the hallway, around the bend where Trivald and his men would have looped around to pincer the escaping inmates. Obviously, they would have gone that way.

Bright blue flashes of light ignited the darkness as various stun guns started firing. Kordal's eyes narrowed.

He took his squad and rushed forward to reinforce Trivald. When he rounded the corner, he swiveled his gun to face down where he thought Trivald should have been.

What he saw made his blood turn to ice. It was a horror show. A field of death. Volgrim ripped apart. Good Volgrim. Strong guards who had served in the prison for

many orbits. They were well trained, modded to the moon and back, and trained to deal with any sort of escape situation.

But now, there were ten bodies ripped in half, torn apart, absolute eviscerated. Their blood and organs coated the walls.

Trivald was among them.

Kordal felt a flash of fear. He couldn't remember the last time something had scared him. Certainly to this extent.

"Movement!" One of the guards behind Kordal shouted.

Kordal raised his eyes.

That was when he saw the monster for the first time.

For humans, the scariest thing in the universe was the unknown. The second scariest thing was something that *looked* human, but was not human. It might have the face of the human, or the general mannerisms, but if something about that *thing* was 'off', it could scare the shit out of even the most battle-hardened man alive.

The Volgrim were no different. What Kordal saw in the darkness ahead was something that should not exist.

It vaguely looked like a Volgrim. But the proportions were all wrong. It has a muscular body, like a Dolgrimite, but it had four-fingered hands, like a Changeling. Eight snake-like appendages fell from the back of its head and buzzed in the air behind it, seemingly levitating from left to right, in search of prey. The creature had beady, blood-red eyes, and deep crimson skin. It was almost completely naked, wearing only the tattered remains of a suit Kordal didn't recognize, as if the creature had molted its skin to grow from a cocoon.

When the creature looked at Kordal, the Technopath knew in an instant.

This thing was a *skinwalker*.

It was an *abomination*.

* * *

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BhckRnNBeh0

"Open fire!!" Kordal shouted, his voice rising an octave higher than it ever had before.

Nobody had the time to judge the fear in his voice. In unison, every Technopath guard started shooting at the horrifying abomination. The creature leaped to the right and its feet collided with the wall. It used the surface as a springboard and pounced at the terrified guards, making all of them yelp in fright. Bullets tracked the creature's movements with military precision, but the damn thing was slippery, and its eight head-tendrils stabbed into the ground and yanked it around, making its movements impossible for even their targeting irises to predict.

The creature jumped toward the right flank. Kordal barely caught the sight of something slender whipping around in the darkness. A guard's guttural cry cut off mid-syllable as his body was sliced in half. It looked like a sword had bisected him from the waist before impaling his head.

Kzzat! Kzzat!

Electrical beams struck the creature and forced it backward a step or two. But then it recovered and charged again, shrugging off attacks that would have incapacitated any Technopath instantly.

Kordal was not standing idly like an idiot. He had jumped backward the moment he ID'd the creature's speedy and erratic movements to put distance between himself and it. One of his hand-tentacles pressed a button on his weapon, switching it to plasma mode. He started firing powerful energized projectiles that melted the wall and floor with 5000-degree bolts of molten plasma. The somewhat slow-firing nature of this mode forced him to aim more carefully, but even with all his training, Kordal found that the creature was too damn slippery! Multiple times, Kordal fired at the creature's after-image, missing it by millimeters. One time, he was sure he'd hit the monster square in the chest, but it threw the body of a fallen guard at Kordal, and he vaporized the dead Volgrim instead.

"Ahh! Die, die you monster!" Kordal roared. By this point, five of the eight guards who came with him were already dead. It hadn't been twenty seconds since the fight began. The abomination had made short work of them.

With each guard that died, the pressure on the monster decreased. It was able to kill the rest faster and faster. Kordal finally managed to get a lucky hit during a brief instant, when the creature was already flinching from an electrical pulse that struck it.

BLAM!

Kordal fired a plasma shot that struck the creature's arm and sent it tumbling against the wall. The monster grunted a little, then quickly got back up.

Kordal's brain was enhanced by several different biomods. Naturally, he was able to perceive things much more quickly than most Technopaths. That was why he was shocked out of his wits when he realized the creature's arm didn't look injured at all!

The skin wasn't even lightly burned.

No! How is that possible?! Kordal thought, his pupils narrowing to pinpricks.

With a flip of the switch, Kordal switched to a Hardened Taser mode. This one was different from the mode his subordinates used. It fired pellets that exploded on contact and turned into web-like strands of exo-steel that would wrap around a target, bind them, and electrocute them.

It wasn't that Kordal wanted to capture the monster alive, but against such a terrifying foe, he hoped this might buy him a minute, even just a few more seconds for reinforcements to arrive.

He was running out of time. In fact, his time was nearly up!

Krrrrt! Krrrrt!

Kordal squeezed the trigger and sent a stream of pellets rapidly firing. Most of them missed the target and struck the opposite wall, or even flew into the cells and exploded on the inmates inside, making them shriek in pain as webs of steel exploded around their bodies and violently electrocuted them.

Finally, one pellet made contact. It struck the monster and exploded, wrapping around it and forcing it to take a step backward as it fought to break free of its constraints.

Frighteningly, the electrocution didn't seem to even give it the jitters. It was as if the electrical energy in the taser couldn't hurt the creature at all.

But Kordal couldn't care about that. With the creature momentarily immobilized, he started pelting it with bullet after bullet, causing more and more webs to explode and wrap around the creature, each web reinforcing the one after it.

"Keep shooting it!!" Kordal shouted. "Don't stop until it's-"

Kordal stopped mid-sentence. He suddenly realized all his men were dead. He was the last one standing.

His eyes flicked left and right, but he didn't stop shooting.

Where are the others?! Kordal thought. *They should have arrived by now! Something's wrong!*

The creature grunted. It kept trying to stand, but the webs of metal engulfing it bit into its skin and squeezed more and more for every layer that enveloped it. The cumulative effect of all of them was far beyond what a single pellet could accomplish.

But Kordal was frightened out of his wits. He had successfully pinned the creature down, but something was wrong. No reinforcements were showing up. They shouldn't have been more than ten seconds behind him, let alone a minute or more! Where was everybody?!

The creature struggled to move. It fought desperately to break free of its restraints, but its movements were slowing.

"Kordal to Top Level, where's my backup?!" Kordal shouted. "Top Level, respond! Top-"

Kordal's heart jumped. He flicked his eyes to the left and saw something that scared him more than anything else so far... and that was saying a lot.

There was another abomination rounding the corner at the end of the hall. This one had bright, neon-yellow skin. It looked even meaner than the one he had pinned down, and the moment it rounded the corner, it spotted Kordal and started sprinting at him.

"Shit, shitshitshit!!" Kordal screamed. He turned his gun to fire at the new creature, but it leaped to the left and the right. It dodged and weaved, causing the tazer-nets to explode harmlessly on the ground or against the cells behind it.

Seven seconds. That was how much time passed between Kordal spotting the golden abomination and it arriving within arm's reach of him.

Kordal felt a strange sensation as one of his arms stopped following his commands. Then the other one as well. He glanced down to see his right arm falling away from his body, but he didn't have time to look for the left one before a powerful hand grabbed him by the throat and violently slammed him against the wall.

The abomination grinned at Kordal and licked its lips.

"Hehehe... you didn't expect me to ever escape, did you, *Commander*? Don't worry. I'm not cruel like you. I won't torture you or drag this out. I just wanted you to know that

I've been waiting for this moment for a long time."

Kordal's eyes widened.

"N-nuh... no... can't be... Ved...ric?"

The creature cocked its head. Its smile became sinister.

Crack.

With a flip of its thumb, it snapped Kordal's neck, and the light started to leave his eyes.

How... could it be... him?

That was the last thought that passed through Kordal's mind before his eyes lost their light. He died tragically, not even knowing what had happened down here. His grievance would be unresolved for the rest of Eternity...

Vedric casually dropped the guard he hated the most to the ground, then turned to look at Unarin.

"Hehehe... caught in a snag? Need help?"

Unarin grunted. He slowly stood up, causing some of the cords binding him to snap, but the majority held tight.

After a few moments, Unarin sighed. "Yes, help me, please."

Vedric chuckled. At once, his Haa'ti lashed out, turning as thin as threads. They sliced through the restraints with the speed of a hurricane, and instantly released Unarin from his predicament.

Unarin cracked his neck. "The others?"

"Taken care of. Why do you think nobody came to bother you down here?" Vedric asked. "But we do have a problem. They sent an SOS off-world. You and I might be strong, but once a real fighting force arrives..."

Unarin smirked. "I've gotten a good feel for this body. It won't be a problem. We'll just need... more."

The two Ascended walked through the lake of gore around them. As they headed toward the exit, Unarin gestured toward the other cells.

"And these people?"

"Leave them." Vedric said coldly. "They're trash. The guards might be bastards, but the people down in this wing belong here."

"Like you and I did?" Unarin questioned.

Vedric chuckled. "Exceptions merely prove a rule, brother Unarin. Before we leave, I can show you the files of everyone here. But we're better off 'recruiting' from medium and low security."

Unarin nodded. "Acceptable."

As the two of them left the maximum security wing, the halls became eerily quiet. The inmates shook with fear after hearing the horrifying sounds and seeing the two monsters that had just ripped apart an entire force of heavily armed guards.

Nobody wanted to attract attention anymore. They all simply prayed they could become invisible to the abominations roaming their halls.

* * *

"This is Reldis Command. We've received a Class V SOS from our southern prison. We are mobilizing all units, but we've lost contact with all guards. We believe this to be a Meltdown Incident. I repeat, a Meltdown Incident. Please contact the Psions and request backup."

The Technopath in charged of Reldis's offworld coordination platform urgently transmitted a plea for help. Based on the fact that more than a hundred heart sensors had gone offline in less than fifteen time-units, that indicated a possible coordinated force attacking the prison to kill the guards. This was beyond what their world's security forces could handle. They were a rimworld after all, existing on the fringes of Technopath space.

A long several minutes passed. Eventually, the response came back.

"Reldis Command, this is General Slifer from the ship Imperial's Might I. We are changing course to assist you, but be advised we are still multiple rotations away from you. I have spoken to the Psions, and they informed me that there was a Cosmic Psion currently located in the vicinity of Reldis. Command, do you copy?"

"A Cosmic Psion?" Command's Technopath coordinator exclaimed. "That will help us greatly. Who is he?"

"Not he, 'she'. She's a 6th Level named Protector Dosena. I don't know if she's off-world or within spitting distance, but if you can contact her, she should be capable of

helping you."

"Much appreciated, General. I will relay this news." The Technopath replied. "Reldis Command, out."

It didn't take long for several orders to get relayed around. Eventually, those orders made their way to the only Psion currently present on Reldis-02.

Levitating in the skies above the capital city, Dosena frowned.

[A prison break? It must be a serious matter. My mission was to investigate the Technopaths here to try and uncover the production location for Exigent-13, yet now my superiors want me to deal with such a minor matter.]

Dosena tapped her chin.

[I suppose there's no helping it. Technopaths are so useless that they can't even handle a conflict of this level. What sad excuses for Volgrim.]

Dosena turned her attention toward the southern prison. Then, she launched her body toward it.

Part 732: Prison Break

Reldis-02. South-side Prison, Minimum Security Wing. Stardate 207.715 of the Ancient Volgrim Empire.

Unarin and Vedric made their way out of the maximum security wing into the middle security wing. Along the way, they encountered several groups of prison guards, but these Volgrim were much weaker than the ones who regularly handled the maximum security wing. They barely managed to put up a fight before the two Ascended brutally slaughtered them.

[Are you sure you're okay with all this murdering?] Vedric asked Unarin as they climbed the stairs to the minimum security wing. [We're going to be fugitives after this.]

[If I had not ascended, I would have perished already.] Unarin said matter-of-factly. [These Volgrim sent me here to die. How many others have they punished in such a way? Those who are willing to kill should not feel surprised when they themselves end up dead. This much is only fair; the law of the jungle and of decency. As for the act of killing itself, I am far from unfamiliar with such a thing. Many have fallen at my hands already.]

The two Ascended did not open their mouths to speak. Their words transmitted to each other telepathically, not because they possessed telepathic abilities, but because of their *Haa'ti*.

It hadn't taken Unarin and Vedric much time to realize their new hair-tendrils had many more purposes than mere decoration. The Haa'ti functioned as eight additional limbs, so they could be used for movement and performing tasks. The eight appendages had all kinds of other strange and bizarre properties as well. They could shrink and stretch, they could change their shape to stab and slash, they were extremely durable, and they also granted both Ascended the ability to communicate with one another when within a certain range.

Through some unknown mechanism, the Haa'ti acted like wireless receivers. The two Ascended became connected to each other when they within a hundred steps of one another, and could transmit thoughts, images, even emotions. Unarin felt closer to Vedric than he ever had anyone else in his life... including his Progenitor.

[I served in the military for two decades before I rose to my position at Father Zaeed's Temple.] Vedric replied. [I, too, have killed many. It is good to see we are both of equal mind on this matter.]

As they marched into the minimum security wing, Vedric paused at the entrance. [Go inside and do what you must. I will stay here and await your return.]

[No need.] Unarin transmitted. [Go to the registry and hack the prisoner archives. Find anyone worth recruiting, then return and bring their names to me. We will need greater numbers if we are to get out of this situation alive.]

[Alright. I shall do that.] Vedric said.

Vedric glanced down at his figure. Once again, he marveled at how his aged and decrepit body had returned to its youthful vigor. He felt as if he had gone from 85 orbits of age all the way back down to the prime of his life, shortly before he had entered the Temple. His mind moved speedily, and his muscles rippled with power.

Becoming an Ascended felt to him as if he had discovered the Fountain of Youth. He likely had many good decades still remaining before he passed.

Vedric turned to leave, but then he paused to look back at Unarin.

[Brother. When I reached the Cosmic Realm, I managed to climb seventy-three steps before my willpower ran dry. How far did you make it?]

Unarin paused. A long several seconds passed before he replied.

[One hundred and fourteen steps.] Unarin eventually answered.

[I knew it!] Vedric gasped. [The Rulers watching me seemed alarmed that as a mortal I had climbed so far, but they didn't seem impressed. You're even more of a monster than I thought!]

Unarin chuckled. [I am nothing much. Let us hurry before reinforcements arrive, Vedric.]

[Of course.]

Vedric continued on his way, splitting off from Unarin while Unarin entered the minimum security wing. Unlike the maximum security wing, this one was brightly illuminated. Vedric had not cut the power here. Thus, when Unarin started walking down the hallways, the prisoners could easily see him.

"What?!"

"A monster? An abomination!!"

"W-what is that thing?!"

Cries of fear and terror quickly rose up as the Technopaths and Changelings imprisoned here, most of them the latter, began crying out in wide-eyed alarm as they saw the hideous creature walking down their hallways.

Perhaps to a Terran, an Ascended might seem visually similar to any other Volgrim, but to the Volgrim, this was not the case at all. Every single facet of Unarin's appearance made him look like a freakish, hideous chimera of sorts. His facial anatomy was wrong. His body proportions appeared bizarre. His Haa'ti looked alien and alarming, and the way his razor-sharp toe-claws *clinked* against the ground made his approach sound frightening beyond belief.

When Unarin swiveled his head from side to side to try and look for Muuxunuu and Randis, he spotted many other Changelings backing into their cells, looking at him with terror in their eyes.

Changelings did not usually express emotions, not even fear. Thus, when these prisoners did so, it showed how frightening his appearance was to them. It broke the limits on their mental conditioning.

In the eyes of both subspecies, the Changelings and the Technopaths, Unarin was like a skinwalker. He resembled a ghoulish abomination assembled from pastiches of multiple different Volgrim subspecies... and not in a flattering way. His tiny, beady eyes gave him the air of a predator. His clawed feet made him look like an animal. His Haa'ti swaying behind his back made him look like a thug and a hoodlum.

On top of all that, Unarin was practically naked! His prisoner outfit had torn to shreds, being far too small for his new body. It clung to him in strips of fabric, making him resemble a wild animal that couldn't properly wear clothes.

Unarin ignored the cries of fear from the prisoners around him. This lack of reaction scared them even more. It was as if a psychopath lacking Volgrim feelings was walking in their midst. A few prisoners even fainted from terror when Unarin casually glanced at them.

"Not the sturdiest grade of individuals." Unarin muttered to himself quietly.

Unarin walked half the cell block before he spotted someone familiar. Unarin paused and turned to face a cell, where he spotted Randis and Muuxunuu together, both of them immediately shrinking back in fear from his gaze.

"Ahh!" Muuxunuu cried out, shrinking back into the corner. "M-m-monster!!"

"W-what is that thing?" Randis whimpered, pressing itself so hard against the wall that it seemed the Changeling was trying to turn into wallpaper to hide itself. "We're going to die!!"

The screams of terror outside the cells didn't help the two Changelings and their states of mind. With dozens of other Changelings crying in fear, it was clear the entire cell block had been thrown into chaos.

Unarin stood, unmoving, for a few moments.

Then he spoke.

"Randis. Is that any way to speak to the one who saved your life?"

Randis shivered. The monster's voice was deep and menacing, decidedly masculine. The Changelings almost couldn't even parse its words, so terrified were they.

"Randis. Muuxunuu." Unarin said slowly. "There is no need to be alarmed. It is I. Unarin."

Randis and Muuxunuu shuddered. Their eyes widened, as difficult as that was for Changelings to even do, and they looked at the creature before them with horror.

"You... you... Unarin?" Randis asked, teeth chattering nonstop. "No. A lie! A deception! If you are Unarin, then what did those jailers do to you?!"

"They did nothing to me." Unarin said, his tone calm and measured. "Randis. I was with you and Muuxunuu when we executed the Thumper Gang. That was only one night ago. As for this body, I have not become a monster. I have... *ascended*. I have become a new form of life. A new Volgrim subspecies, above all the others."

The more Unarin talked, the more Randis and Muuxunuu calmed down. His words were reasonable, and his posture non-threatening. The fact he could speak meant he was not some rabid beast, and therefore could be reasoned with. The idea that he was actually Unarin seemed a little plausible, but his other claims seemed somewhat far-fetched.

Randis narrowed its eyes. It carefully took a step away from the wall.

"You are... Unarin?" Randis questioned. "Truly?"

"I am he." Unarin answered.

Several seconds passed. Randis carefully looked Unarin up and down, trying to match details it knew about Unarin to the strange creature before it. Ultimately, it was Muuxunuu who stepped forward.

"This one is familiar with Unarin. The creature before us speaks in the same way Unarin would. Its skin is the same color as Unarin, and it even has the same speckled-patterns on its shoulders and head. Whether it is truly an 'Ascended' life form as it claims, or whether Unarin was experimented on until it became this creature, that is the only question left in this one's mind."

Unarin smiled. "You have a good memory, Muuxunuu. Do you remember when we were inside the nebula being chased by the X-73 Vantablack? While you were clearly afraid of death, you kept your emotions muted then, much more so than a few moments ago. It seems you are not as emotionless as you like to believe."

Muuxunuu blinked, then lowered its head. "This Ascended is Unarin. Without a doubt."

The two Changelings visibly relaxed. They looked at Unarin with eyes full of expectation. Already, the noise outside had died down a lot, and many Changelings had drawn closer to the bars to listen as Unarin spoke. While the ones further away had no idea what was going on, the closest Changelings could hear Unarin's words, and they relayed those words to other Changelings further down the line.

"What caused this... transformation?" Muuxunuu asked after walking closer to the prison cell bars.

"That is a long story." Unarin replied. "Simply put, I discovered that there has been a grand conspiracy to deceive countless Volgrim across the entire Empire. By unraveling that conspiracy, I attained enlightenment, and thus, I was able to elevate my mind, body, and soul to a new level."

A momentary silence fell before Unarin lifted his hand to point a finger at Muuxunuu.

"You and Randis can also obtain this power, if your minds are strong, and your willpower firm."

Muuxunuu hesitated. "How... does this... 'power' work?"

Randis walked over and stopped beside Muuxunuu. The obsidian-skinned Changeling's eyes flared up with interest. "How powerful have you become, Unarin?"

It was clear at a glance that Muuxunuu's will was not as sturdy as Randis. Even though the two of them had cowered in fright earlier, they had both gotten over their fears quickly. But now, it was the fear of the unknown that threatened to hold them back. Only, Randis conquered his fear much more swiftly than Muuxunuu.

"I cannot answer that question properly." Unarin replied. "But, to summarize in a word, I have become... stronger."

Randis blinked. Unarin's description was anything but specific. Even so, Randis was drawn in by Unarin's charismatic tone.

"Can this one also become... stronger?" Randis asked.

"Of course." Unarin answered. "But there is a chance you might die. The ascension process is dangerous. If you are not absolutely certain, you should remain as you are."

"This one is certain." Randis said, immediately stepping toward the cell bars. "This one tires of standing by while atrocities happen. Only with strength can this one rise up against the flawed system imprisoning all of us. This one wishes to become a player in the great game of politics, not a mere playing piece."

Unarin and Randis locked eyes. After several seconds of silence, Unarin nodded.

"Very good then."

He reached out, grabbed the cell door, and tore it off his hinges, making the other two gasp in shock. He wasn't lying. His strength was monstrous!

Unarin took a step forward. He reached out a finger, then he touched Randis's forehead.

The effect was immediate. Randis closed its eyes, then the Changeling's body instantly began to morph. At once, the Changeling stopped being a genderless entity, and his body became gendered. He grew outward more than upward, only rising a few centimeters in height, but his muscles drastically changing as his body inflated in mass. From a tall, gangly creature with no muscle mass to speak of, he became a powerhouse rippling with strength. His eyes shrunk. Haa'ti grew from the back of his head. He quickly came to resemble the same sort of species as Unarin, but a closer look would reveal the two of them had their own differences.

"I... I succeeded." Randis said, his deep voice momentarily startling himself. "I made it up the staircase..."

He blinked and looked around the cell. Then he looked at his body. He couldn't help but lift his hands and marvel at the strength contained within his palms.

"How many steps did you climb?" Unarin asked.

Randis blinked. He puffed out his chest and grinned, an expression that would have been uncharacteristic of himself less than a minute before.

"One hundred and seventy five!" Randis boasted. "And you?"

"One hundred and fourteen steps." Unarin said with a smile. "You have bested me, Randis."

"Hahaha!" Randis laughed wildly before clapping a palm on Unarin's shoulder. "There is nothing to be ashamed of. The Rulers gave me a boon due to my exploits! I used it well!"

Unarin patted Randis's shoulder back. He did not ask Randis what boon he had requested of Akasha.

"Muuxunuu?" Unarin asked, turning to the final remaining member of the trio. "Are you willing to risk Ascension as well?"

Muuxunuu glanced back and forth between Unarin and Randis. There was no fear in the Changeling's eyes. Seeing was believing. Now that Randis served as confirmation of what could be obtained, Muuxunuu did not wait any longer.

"This one is ready."

Unarin nodded. Less than a minute later, Muuxunuu's body rapidly morphed and shifted. No longer genderless, the Changeling became the first female Ascended of their species, though her body was no less powerful than either of the other two. Her voice downshifted in pitch slightly, and her appearance became... quite attractive to both of the other two. It was as if their sensibilities had immediately changed after Ascension.

"You succeeded." Unarin said warmly, smiling at the newest member of his species. "Congratulations."

"How many steps did you climb?" Randis immediately asked.

Muuxunuu touched her face and examined her hands. She looked at a mirror on the wall and felt that her new appearance was... sublime.

"I only managed to climb one hundred and fifty four steps." Muuxunuu said, her voice soft. "It seems Randis is the most powerful of us now."

Unarin gently squeezed Muuxunuu's shoulder. "Do not sell yourself short. We are, all of us, powerful. And together? We will become unstoppable."

Unarin turned to face the other prisoners.

"All of you have seen who I am and what I can do. My only question to you now is... are you willing to remain locked behind bars? Will you choose to take a chance on Ascension and become one of us?!"

Several nearby Changelings grabbed the bars of their cells and shivered with excitement. Seeing was believing, and Unarin had proven multiple times that he could accomplish this seemingly impossible feat with merely a touch of his finger.

The Changelings here were, for the most part, not truly criminals. Many of them had been put in prison for far lesser crimes than Unarin and the other two, and most of those charges had been trumped-up in order to terrorize the local Changeling population.

The Changelings were unwilling to live like caged animals! With the opportunity in front of them, many let out cries of acceptance! Unarin grinned, then walked over to the nearest cell. He touched the forehead of one of the Changelings, and that one roared with power as it too became an Ascended.

"Thirty seven steps!" The new Ascended cried.

Unarin uplifted another Changeling. "Seventeen steps!"

"Twenty-nine steps!"

"Seventy steps!"

"One hundred and two steps!"

"Forty-four steps!"

One by one, Unarin elevated the status of Changeling after Changeling, causing them to become far more powerful than they ever could have imagined. Unarin smiled, but at the same time, he was taking mental notes.

It seems I am truly an outlier, along with Muuxunuu and Randis. These prisoners have had their wills broken, and few are able to cross the threshold of one hundred steps. Even so, the Rulers told me that mortals making it to the tenth step were few and far between. Even the worst of the stock here greatly exceed that threshold!

Unarin was not uplifting these Changelings randomly. He found that after Muuxunuu and Randis became Ascended, his Haa'ti had grown more powerful when it came to their transmission range. Each new Ascended allowed their species to communicate from greater and greater distances away. Thus, Unarin was able to converse with Vedric, who had obtained the prisoner's files, and verify which prisoners had not committed terrible crimes.

Unarin was in a rush to add more Ascended to his ranks, but he would not uplift criminals and thugs!

It was on the 13th ascension that something unfortunate happened. The Changeling Unarin had chosen let out a horrible scream, then its body abruptly inflated like a balloon before exploding in a horrifying shower of guts and viscera.

"Ugh!" Unarin exclaimed, lifting his arm to shield his face right before that Changeling detonated. Blood and guts sprayed all over him, and that unfortunate Changeling's cellmate. The Cellmate's expression turned to horror, its emotionless facade cracking under the shock of witnessing its friend perish.

Unarin pulled back and looked around. The excitement of the remaining Changelings had immediately taken a nose-dive, seeing what happened to that one.

"Everyone." Unarin said after taking a minute to calm his heart and wipe the guts from his face. "This is to be expected. Not all of you are worthy to become Ascended. If your willpower is low, or if you have fear in your heart, you should not accept my favor. If you are too weak, this will be the result."

Unarin successfully turned the situation around, but the quality of the remaining Changeling prisoners continued to fall. More of them exploded than ascended, and eventually, the rest gave up, preferring to treasure their lives over a nebulous power that might ultimately kill them.

In total, fifty-four Ascended emerged. Thirty Changelings died, but the new army of Ascended proved to be a formidable start for a species that had only existed for less than an hour.

Unarin was about to head down to the Middle Security level when Vedric's voice spoke to him telepathically.

[Unarin. We have company. There's a powerful Psion outside.]

Unarin frowned. [I'll come to assist you.]

[No need.] Vedric retorted. [I'll handle it. I *hate* Psions.]

[Suit yourself. Call us if you need help.] Unarin said.

And so, he headed down into the Middle Security section of the prison, while his new underlings spread out, unlocking the equipment rooms to arm themselves with weapons and armor.

Before long, the security forces would arrive. That was when the *real* fight would begin.

* * *

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Volgarius. Unarin's Sanctum, Inside the Founder's Thumb.

Unarin regaled Vulpanix with a tale so shocking that if she had a mouth, it would certainly be hanging ajar. He spoke while Dosena remained mostly silent, only interjecting once in a while to explain her own point of view.

[I have heard none of this in the past, besides a few throwaway comments when I was still an Initiator.] Vulpanix said quietly. [There are so many shocking revelations... I do not even know where to begin asking questions.]

Unarin did not say anything. Neither did Dosena. The two remained silent for a full minute as Vulpanix organized the questions spiraling within her mind.

Eventually, she did speak.

[First Founder... you are... strong?]

Unarin nodded. "In a manner of speaking, yes."

[You have climbed more steps on the Akashic Stairs than even I have.] Vulpanix said, her tone glum. [I only managed to climb 112 steps when I reached the 7th Level, and that was after conceptualizing the idea of Temporal Clones. It was a huge improvement in my mindset and combat philosophy. Even Administrator Muuxunuu has climbed more steps

then me, as well as your brother, Randis. I have never felt so lowly and weak as I do today.]

She paused before directing a strange stare at Unarin. [But... if you did manage to climb so many steps, why are you not a Cosmic? You should have the aura of one, yet I do not sense anything at all! How is such a thing possible? Are all the Ascended monsters like you?]

Unarin smiled. "The concept of 'Cosmic Power' is often misunderstood. Even I did not comprehend it in my youth. It was only long after the Volgrim Empire was created, after the defeat of the Sentinels, long beyond the end of the Great Wars, that I understood what I had become. But... some things should not be spoken of in public. You never know who is listening."

Vulpanix's skin paled slightly. She wanted to press Unarin for more answers, but his hint that spies could be watching reminded her that even though the Wordsmith might be dead, he also might have left behind arrangements for the humans to spy on the Founders.

The most dangerous weapon was one an enemy did not know about and could not see coming. This was something any tactician knew, and Vulpanix was no fool in that regard.

Eventually, Vulpanix looked at Unarin with inquisitive eyes.

[How powerful are the Ascended? Can they be relied on to help us turn this war around?]

"The answer to that question is anyone's guess." Unarin replied cryptically. "But as my memories have shown, my species could be said to be the strongest of all the subspecies, or at least the most well-rounded. Even so, we are neither infallible nor invulnerable. And recently, the performance of the Dolgrimites has shown that some of our unique strengths have become... replicable."

[What do you mean by that?] Vulpanix pressed.

"The answer will become apparent within less time than you know." Unarin answered, his words as mysterious as ever. "But, more importantly, my time with you has to end. Dosena will carry on with the tales of the ancient times. She knows nearly everything that I do, and has also absorbed the knowledge of many fallen Psions, Ascended, Technopaths, and others who willingly gave their memories to her to preserve our heritage. Even when

we performed the Great Reset to completely alter the manner in which Psions cultivated, we retained the most important knowledge within Dosena's mind, and my own."

Unarin stood up. Vulpanix stood as well, seeing that it seemed he was about to leave.

[Where are you going?] She asked, realizing a moment later that her question was too presumptuous and disrespectful. Luckily, Unarin did not seem to mind.

"A great many events have occurred recently, and now I must handle one of those matters personally." Unarin replied. "Unfortunately, with Dosena out of commission, this duty falls upon me. On any other occasion, she would handle this situation, but such is the way of Karma. What goes around will ultimately come around."

Unarin lightly nodded at Vulpanix, then he folded his hands behind his back, turned on his heel, and strode away. He walked down the side stairs of his Sanctum, pushed open its great doors, and departed without another word.

Several minutes passed. Vulpanix sat back down at the table, but she did not immediately converse with Dosena. The Second Founder, for her part, looked off into the distance, seemingly admiring a painting of an ancient Dolgrimite on the far wall.

[There were many formidable figures in the ancient past.] Dosena eventually said. She could not transmit her thoughts, but Vulpanix was already tapped into the surface layer of her mind, so she could easily communicate with her junior. [Assuming I were in my normal condition, I would certainly be the strongest figure in the modern Volgrim Empire. But I am by no means the most powerful Volgrim who has ever lived in our galaxy. Legend has it the first Supremator died while attempting to ascend to the 10th Level. I have spent my entire existence attempting to break past that barrier, albeit without success.]

She paused.

[It has been my greatest shame. I am truly unworthy.]

Vulpanix frowned. It was deeply uncomfortable for her to hear such words coming from the one Volgrim she revered more than any other in the Empire. She had idolized Dosena her entire life, but now her idol was crippled, potentially unable to return to her peak power for a very long time, and could be easily assassinated by a rogue agent, if one existed.

Even now, Vulpanix could reach out and kill Dosena with a single thought. She had no doubt the Second Founder was at her mercy. She would never do such a thing, but the fact it was possible… frightened her.

[Our Empire is so weak now.] Vulpanix said quietly. [I feel great fear, Second Founder. I fear we will not survive the coming war. I fear our days are numbered, and we will soon perish to our many, many enemies.]

[Haha.] Dosena laughed lightly, unperturbed by her junior's words. [If our Empire falls, so be it. It is only death. Death is a natural part of the Great Cycle. 99.999% of all creatures that have ever existed have already died. Ancient monsters standing strong at the level of Apex Cosmic were helpless against the forces of the Akashic Cycle. When this Eternity ends, all beings except for the Rulers will perish to the fading winds of time.]

She paused before adding, [And even those Rulers, do you think they are immortal? Far from it. Rulers rise and fall. Only Akasha has proven to be unmovable. Some of his greatest Heralds have perished while infighting amongst one another. As for the ordinary Rulers? Our Creator died, the Dark One will someday die, everyone will die. There is no reason to worry about such deaths, for you and I will assuredly both perish someday.]

Dosena's calm words did nothing to stifle the fear in Vulpanix's heart. She considered herself relatively broad-minded, but in truth, she had never thought about the existential truth of her mortality. Having it all laid out by Dosena made Vulpanix's skin turn pale.

[Oh, look at you. Such a cute junior.] Dosena teased. But then, her expression turned sharp.

[Vulpanix. Do you truly believe our Empire is at its wits' end? Do you think we have exhausted all of our last-resort options? Do you think we lack options for dealing with the problems surrounding us?]

Vulpanix slowly shook her head. [Of course not, Second Founder. But… unleashing the Sentinels would be…]

[I do not speak of the *Sentinels*.] Dosena said with a sneer. [There are secrets that even the you of now is not qualified to know. Unarin and I do not keep many secrets from one another, but the secrets we do keep are sure to be frightening beyond belief. Even now, I am not as helpless as I might appear… and neither is *he*. The Sentinels are merely our most obvious, clumsy, and brutish weapon of last resort. But I have at least two other possibilities at my disposal. I cannot even guess how many Unarin possesses.]

Vulpanix lifted her head. She looked at Dosena in shock.

[What? You're saying you don't know what Unarin is planning? What cards he's hiding?]

[Unarin mastered the Mind of Void long ago. I have long been unable to read his thoughts. Similarly, he cannot read mine. This is not a problem we were unable to resolve, but an unspoken agreement we held. It keeps us both in check. If he were to grow power-mad and throw the Empire away, or if I were to do so, or if one of us were to be mind-controlled or otherwise compromised, we would both have secret weapons we could deploy. The same is true of the other Founders, perhaps to a lesser extent. I am certain Cuanali has stashed away a few secret weapons for a worst-case scenario.]

Vulpanix nodded. She fell silent for a moment.

[Is this why Archangel Uzziel has not wiped out our Empire? Surely by now, even before the Plague became empowered, even before our Psions fell to Demila, she had the capability to launch an all-out assault on Volgarius, but she didn't. Now that we are far weaker, she still could, but she does not. I have believed for a while now that merely wanting to make us suffer felt like a rather flimsy reason for not attacking...]

[It is presumably a combination of many reasons.] Dosena acknowledged. [Unarin and I did not know Uzziel was the mastermind of the Kolvaxian scourge. We believed the probability they were extra-galactic invaders was the highest likelihood. Even so, Unarin had certainly posited on a few occasions that the angels might be behind the rise of the Kolvaxians, but he lacked sufficient proof to establish a credible chain of evidence for that scenario. Given that we possessed what we believed to be Uzziel's soul, it seemed unlikely she had created them. The other Archangels, naturally, had become mere slaves to the demons.]

Vulpanix thought for a moment.

[Regarding the Ascended. What exactly are they? Are they a superior species of Volgrim? Are they our next evolutionary step? Unarin's vision demonstrated that Changelings and Technopaths can become Ascended... what about Psions and Dolgrimites?]

Dosena sighed. [All four subspecies can become Ascended. Only a hundred or so Dolgrimites ever took up the opportunity, and 75% of them died. I do not believe this is

due to an incompatibility with their physiology, but because most were low-echelon Dolgrimites with mindsets that were not conducive to the process of ascension.]

She continued. [As for Psions… we certainly can become Ascended. However, there are a few things one must understand before making such a choice. First of all, every species has its own value. The Dolgrimites are stronger in physical body than the Ascended. The Psions possess more psionic might than the Ascended. Changelings can adapt their bodies to new forms far better than the Ascended. And Technopaths will always be superior in the realm of technological comprehension and manipulation than any Ascended.]

[Furthermore,] Dosena continued, [Not all Ascended are the same. The Ascended are essentially a blending of all the subspecies. They are what we Volgrim would have likely evolved into had the Dark Dragon not altered us. With historical insight, we now know it was Dolgris who was manipulating our species behind the scenes. Dolgris split our one species into four different ones to weaken us in some ways and strengthen us in others. The wars we fought made us evolve our combat prowess quickly, but they also kept us divided. In the end, Dolgris only retained control over the Dolgrimites, while the rest of us went our own way, unaware of his existence.]

[What do you mean when you say the Ascended are not all the same?] Vulpanix asked, confused. [Surely they would be different individually. I would expect as much.]

[Ah, I misspoke.] Dosena clarified. [A species that ascends affects the Ascended they become. Changeling Ascended are not the same as Technopath Ascended, Psion Ascended, or Dolgrimite Ascended. Even within the Ascended, there are crucial variations. Dolgrimites make for far more powerful Ascended when it comes to their bodies. Psions retain much, but not all, of their psionic potential. Technopaths are more adept than the other Ascended at manipulating technology. And of course, Changelings have much more flexible bodies that can adapt in a variety of ways that might surprise you.]

Vulpanix looked interested. [If that is true, then why did you not become an Ascended? Can I become one?]

[It is no longer possible for either of us.] Dosena explained. [One can only become an Ascended if they possess a mortal body. Now that you have attained Cosmic power, you would only perish if you attempted the transition. Therefore, only Psions of the 5th Level

and below may become Ascended. Beyond that, there are of course the requirements for a formidable mind and willpower, but that goes without saying. For Psions, becoming an Ascended is rarely a worthwhile prospect.]

Seeing the confusion in Vulpanix's eyes, Dosena elaborated further. [We Psions can already become Cosmic by focusing our minds and studying the Psionic arts. If a Psion happened to lack the ability to climb past the mortal level, then their willpower would already be quite poor, and they would likely die during the transition. Therefore, one must be an excellent Psion seed, yet one who does not wish to attain Cosmic power through their own species' methods. Naturally, this type of Psion almost never exists.]

Vulpanix was enlightened. [It would seem the vast majority of Ascended consisted of Changelings and Technopaths, then. And likely there were more of the former than the latter.]

[Changelings maintain extremely disciplined minds.] Dosena admitted. [Compared to the scatterbrained researchers among the Technopaths, Changelings are already adept at regulating their emotions and maintaining calmness in the face of adversity. They naturally possess strong willpower and high ascension potential. That is why, of all the Ascended that have ever existed, 65% of them came from the ranks of the Changelings, while 30% came from the Technopaths, and only 5% rose from the Psions and the Dolgrimites. Of course, if the Psions decided to advance our powers by becoming Ascended, we would have the highest success rates by far, but there simply isn't any need. Better to diversify the potential of the Volgrim war machine than to go all-in on one tactic. That is how empires fall.]

Vulpanix nodded. It was clear to her now that her horizons had been truly shallow before today.

[Then... with all the Ascended at our disposal, once we unleash them, won't we be able to crush the Archangels into cosmic dust? Why has the First Founder not done so yet?]

For the first time, Dosena appeared stumped. [Matters regarding the Ascended have never been of interest to me. Six million cycles ago, Unarin put the Ascended to sleep inside of hibernation pods to preserve their battle power, but also to train their minds in a virtual world made by Cuanali. At the same time, their hibernation ensures their bodies require minimal sustenance. They will only be awoken when the time of true need arrives... but that time is entirely up to Unarin to determine. I have no say in the matter.]

Vulpanix looked vexed, but she decided not to press the issue. Who was she to argue with the wisdom of a ten million cycles-old leader like Unarin? He had his own plans, and it had been ingrained in Vulpanix since her formation that the First Founder's wisdom was never to be questioned unless he requested it first.

[It would be best if you focused on growing your own base of power, Vulpanix.] Dosena said curtly. [Worry not about the First Founder, and more about how you can someday rise to the rank of Supremator.]

Vulpanix looked surprised. [You will allow me to do so?]

[Your ascension has become a necessity.] Dosena admitted [My psionics are crippled. The Empire requires a new champion in my absence. Even when I regain my former power, I will want a spear for our Empire, while I shall act as the homeworld's shield, or vice-versa. You are too young to know this, but my permanent placement on Volgarius was not always the case. I have only stationed myself here following the rise of the Kolvaxians, but in the past I used to be far more mobile, traveling the cosmos to enlighten myself. I miss it dearly.]

Vulpanix and Dosena chatted a while longer, but eventually, Dosena steered the conversation back around to its starting point.

[Enough idle chatter. I still have much to enlighten you about, with regards to the Ancient Volgrim Empire. The next part of the tale took place when I arrived at the prison facility, shortly after the Ascended began to emerge...]

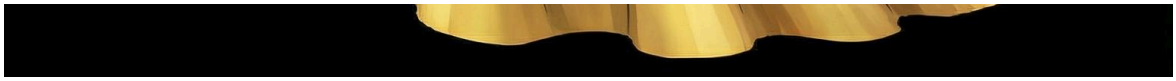
And so, like that, Dosena once again continued the story of the Ancient Volgrim Empire for her junior's benefit...

* * *

Author notes: Here are all the Ascended so far, with Art for each of them!

Unarin

Muuxunuu



Randis

There is no art for Vedric. Unarin was drawn by a human, while Muuxunuu and Randis are AI-variants of the Unarin image. In the future, I might generate an image for Vedric, or I might be able to pay an artist to redraw everyone. For now though, the description of the Haa'ti having 8 tendrils overrides all the artworks, and I imagine the density of the Haa'ti is closer to Muuxunuu than Unarin or Randis.

Part 733: Making a Mindverse

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Inside the Hall of Heroes.

Mandy wasn't in a bad mood, but she wasn't in a good mood either. A few weeks had passed since Blake's crowning ceremony as the Lord of Heroes. In that time, Mandy had been as busy as always.

She was a Runemaster, sometimes referred to as a Runesmith, and even other variations beyond those two. Fundamentally, Mandy manipulated Runes. That was what she did... and it was an ability unique to her.

Most people had zero idea what sort of powers she possessed. Even the people who did know, didn't know much. It wasn't that Mandy deliberately kept them in the dark, but more that they could only see the final products she produced... not the underlying system that governed how her magic functioned. Put another way, Mandy was like a programmer, and the code she wrote was a mystery to everyone. All they could see were the programs she released, with little to no understanding of the code running underneath.

Mandy had explained her abilities many times in the past to her closest family members. Only her father had once comprehended her powers to a decent degree, while her mother was lost, her brother Levi was totally oblivious, and Blake tried to pretend to understand, but it was clear he couldn't follow along either. The one person who had fully and completely understood her powers was Solomon, and that was only due to the intimate mind link they had shared whenever she borrowed his artifact from her father on several occasions.

Mandy was a resident of the Hall of Heroes in the most permanent sense of the word. She was born and had lived there her entire life. Traveling to Realspace was simply not something she did much, nor something she had much interest in doing. She had spent time with her 'aunts' and 'uncles' in realspace, people like Neil and Linda Adams, his secretary Debra who was also Annette's sister, Henry, and others along with them. But despite this, Mandy simply didn't enjoy going to realspace.

War was approaching, and its presence drew nearer every day.

Unlike her brothers, Mandy was a deeply cerebral person. She didn't speak much, and she thought a lot. She was only fifteen years old when she had her first contact with Solomon's Crown, shortly after awakening her powers, and this brief interaction had also allowed her to rapidly enhance her intelligence, and ultimately develop a Mind Realm.

Mandy's Mind Realm was special. It was far more unique than even the Mind Realms her father and uncle, both of the Wordsmiths, had developed.

Mandy sat inside her library, a place stocked with countless books written in Runes, a language only she and Solomon could properly read. The pages of each book were imbued not with words, but with the True Knowledge Mandy had etched onto the pages with her magic. And now, she was reading one of her earlier works with a look of disappointment on her face.

"The theory is simply wrong. How could I have made such an elementary mistake? The confines of my Mind Realm simply cannot expand any further until this error is resolved."

Mandy held a long feather in her right hand, one which had a faintly glowing golden quill-tip at its end. She scratched some runes onto the paper which flickered with energy before erasing other runes that already existed on the page. Immediately, the True Meaning of the page changed, but this only made her expression more miserable.

"No, no, not like that. What am I even doing? I cannot keep making these mistakes. If I don't decipher the solution soon, then I'll have wasted the last 13 years of my life!"

Mandy stared at the page for a good couple of minutes, then she set it down, along with the magical quill, then she took a seat and closed her eyes. Mandy held both hands up on either side of her head, then pinched her fingers together and brought them close to the outside edges of her closed eyes. She wiggled her unpinched fingers, then she slowly pulled her hands forward in front of her face and started to draw symmetrical lines in the air before herself.

Mandy's eyes remained tightly closed. If her right hand drew an upward line, her left hand drew a line downward. If her right hand moved right, her left hand moved left.

Like this, she spent a full minute carefully drawing a magical rune in midair. Then she held her hands in place, opened her eyes, and exhaled deeply.

Slowly, carefully, she lowered the rune down toward her right knee. Her forehead began to sweat as she looked at her flesh and blood body, but what she saw was not what

anyone else would be able to see. Instead, Mandy possessed eyes that were able to innately see the runic configurement of the world around her. The entire world was filled with magic that only she could perceive, and she used her unique Runemaster powers to contemplate and comprehend the true reality only her eyes beheld.

Her legs were dense with magical runic markings. So were her arms, her torso, her face and head, her fingers, even her toes. These runic patterns were not normal, but had been artificially constructed one at a time ever since she had first learned of her powers and started experimenting on herself.

The runes were densely interwoven new, and adding new ones was a major affair that took all her concentration to pull off. A single incorrectly placed element could wrack her body with injuries, illness, and possibly even death. She had certainly screwed up in the past and had to make adjustments on the fly while on the verge of death.

At this moment, her brow was knitted tightly as she slowly shrank the new rune down and carefully placed it onto her right knee. To her relief, the rune vanished, then reappeared amidst the web of markings on her body.

"Succ...success..." Mandy exhaled, breathing through her mouth and nose in equal measure.

This five minute ordeal had drained her thoughts, but it didn't take long before she recovered by pulling from a secret wellspring of mental energy that rapidly replenished itself in her Mind Realm.

Mandy closed her eyes. She looked inside her Mind Realm, and what she saw would have surely startled either of the Wordsmiths, especially Jason Hiro. There were countless soul-like lifeforms floating around in her Mind Realm, as well as a rich and lush-looking world filled with mountains, valleys, lakes and seas, forests, and even floating cities in the clouds. Unfortunately, the spiritual life forms inside Mandy's Mind Realm were not particularly smart, and they definitely weren't sentient.

The most they could do was mindlessly toil away to maintain the stability of her Mind Realm. They did not have thoughts, dreams, or ambitions. They could hardly even be called 'alive'.

Mandy frowned. The new rune she had just placed was designed to augment her life energy to produce more of it inside her mind, but unfortunately, the impact on her Mind Realm was negligible.

Her expression deflated, and a sense of hopelessness overtook her.

"Another failure." Mandy muttered.

She had been trying for so long, but always failing. Her goal was extreme, but she felt success was possible. She just didn't know how to make what she wanted to happen, happen.

Mandy leaned back in her chair and hung her head backward, feeling mentally exhausted in a way even her magic couldn't fix. She had attempted more than 5,000 different times to try and modify a certain part of her Mind Realm, but she hadn't yet succeeded. If she had, everything would've changed.

As Mandy sat there, motionless, she heard soft footsteps approaching from outside her library. She turned her head slightly to see Hammurabi approaching. He paused at the doorway and smiled.

"Am I interrupting anything?" Hammurabi asked.

Mandy blinked her eyelids heavily. "No, nothing at all. Can I help you?"

"You've been cooped up in here for over a week." Hammurabi said, the muscular old man smiling kindly as he entered the room. "I thought I'd make sure you hadn't worked yourself to death."

Mandy looked away. She didn't reply for a time.

It took her a while to come up with anything worth saying.

"I'm so... frustrated with myself." Mandy eventually said, her voice quiet. "I keep trying to do something with my magic, but I can't get it to work. According to my theories, it should be possible, but I keep screwing up, over and over. The weight of my failures is really starting to weigh on me, especially with the situation continuing to worsen in Realspace."

Hammurabi grabbed a chair against the wall and walked with it over to sit down near Mandy. He folded his hands in his lap and nodded seriously.

"I don't understand much of how your runes work, but perhaps you can explain the problem to me in broad terms? Maybe my listening ear can help you disentangle the problem?"

Hammurabi was one of the wisest people Mandy knew, but unlike Solomon who could interface directly with Mandy's mind, Hammurabi struggled to understand her complex theories. Mandy seemed doubtful about whether he could help her, but at the same time, she didn't want to be rude.

"Well..." Mandy said hesitantly. "It's... it's like this. I have a theory about my Mind Realm. Well, most Mind Realms, even. I lack direct experience with other people's Mind Realms, but- sorry, I'm babbling. The point is, I have a theory about Mind Realms, which is that they can be so much more than what we know."

Hammurabi raised an eyebrow. "Interesting. I am quite familiar with Mind Realms. I possessed one when I was alive, as did Solomon. Unfortunately, upon my death, mine ceased to exist. All who perish bring their Mind Realms to the grave along with their bodies."

Mandy nodded. "Solomon told me the same thing. But see, that's the thing. I don't believe that to be a given. I think Mind Realms are actually a 'seed' that can sprout into something far greater if given the proper care."

She continued. "Mind Realms are limited to only containing life forms that are ethereal or spiritual in nature, see? That is how just by holding your artifacts, other living Heroes can interface your souls with their Mind Realms. Dad told me when he and Jason first interfaced with Solomon, their Mind Realms seemed completely barren and empty, but Solomon was able to forcefully create small things like chairs and tables for himself to sit at."

She continued. "I spoke to the Archangels too, and Raphael once told me that he was able to drastically enrich Uncle Jason's Mind Realm by force, using his own knowledge of Mind Realms to create buildings, plants, and other similar things, though purely for aesthetic purposes. Later, Jason added some features to his Mind Realm, creating a sort of rudimentary computer system to boost Aunt Fiona's mental capabilities."

Hammurabi stroked his beard. "Indeed, I have heard some of this. So is that your goal? To create a computer system inside your mind?"

"I can already do that." Mandy said. "But no, that's not my goal. I want to create... well, it might sound a little ludicrous... but I want to make a real, physical, living *world* inside my Mind Realm. What I envision is not a Mind Realm, but a *Mindverse*. I want to create a living world where real people from the real world can travel to and live safely, and one

that could even persist after my death. I also want to find a way to replicate it in the minds of other people!"

This time, Hammurabi was the one who looked doubtful.

"You wish... for real people to live inside a Mind Realm?"

"A *Mindverse*." Mandy corrected, her tone surprisingly firm. "A world or a star system or even a universe within one person's mind. I believe it should be possible."

Hammurabi scratched his chin. "Child, if you think it to be possible, then I trust your judgment. However, in all my years, across the many Heroes I've met, none have ever possessed such a wonder within their minds. I believe you may be grabbing at a prize that extends beyond your arm's reach."

Mandy sighed. "I am starting to think it's hopeless too. But if my dad were still alive, I bet he could have done it. Wordsmithing had all sorts of capabilities, and I feel a Mindverse wouldn't have been out of reach. I just... I need to figure out how to simulate the natural laws of the world, but that's the hardest part since I cannot simulate what I don't know."

Hammurabi thought for a while.

"You once told me you could see runes in all aspects of the world around you. Is there a way you can see the runes related to concepts missing inside your Mindverse?"

The Runemaster threw her hands up helplessly. "I don't know. Maybe? But what I'm missing are truly vague and high level concepts, like 'time' and 'space'. I don't know how to make runes based on the concept of life force, or turning spiritual life forms into flesh and bone, or other such things like that. There's too many concepts eluding me! I fear I will never be able to make my Mindverse a possibility."

"No." Hammurabi said, flashing a knowing smile at her. "That is *not* what you fear. You are an obsessive. The more you try to make this Mindverse a reality, the closer you will draw, and the harder you will work as you see the goal drawing near. It is not failure you fear, but rather, that instead of working on this 'Mindverse', you would be serving humanity better by building weapons of war. You worry that you are frivolously wasting time creating a Mindverse, and that the demons or the Volgrim or the Plague will exterminate humanity due to your poor choice of what to focus on."

Hammurabi chuckled. "I truly love your heart, young one. You have nothing to fear. You are thirty-five years old. You might still feel like a child at times, but you are notably older than many of the most famous Heroes were when they accomplished their greatest feats. You are old enough that you are beginning to develop 'instincts' related to your powers. This 'feeling' you possess regarding the viability of your Mindverse is not something you should ignore."

He continued. "Furthermore, do not disrespect your brothers, the other Heroes in this hall, or even the ordinary humans in Realspace by over-inflating your importance. Even *if* you fell into a deep depression tomorrow and stopped using your magic entirely, humanity would be far from helpless. Jepthath's Legion alone, combined with the imminent rise of empowered humans lacking their Flaw, this is only one possible factor that could result in an explosion of human power."

Mandy looked at Hammurabi and sighed. "I... think I get it. You're saying that if I feel this Mindverse thing is worth the time and effort, I should devote myself to it and not feel guilt at not serving humanity in a more immediate context. Is that right?"

"Precisely!" Hammurabi exclaimed, before letting out a belly-laugh. "Hahaha, my dear girl, you've got it! That's exactly right. Focus on what your instincts tell you to focus on, and even if you fail at creating this 'Mindverse', you will surely discover new aspects to your power that can help you in other ways. So long as you learn something new every day, there is no waste."

A long moment of silence followed.

Hammurabi cleared his throat. "However, I do have one suggestion."

Mandy clasped her hands respectfully. "Please advise, teacher."

"You stated that you do not know how to uncover high-level aspects of reality. Time and space, for instance. But have you forgotten? You once told me your runic arts are somewhat similar to the magic the Fairies use to build their formations. Humanity plans to swallow the Sharmur star-system, along with the Pixiv system, into the Cube. Why not pay those Fairies a visit after we've done so? I have a feeling they might know about these high-level concepts. They could be of great help to you in empowering your Mindverse... and they are humanity's natural allies to boot! You will be in little danger of betrayal by them."

Hope's daughter was enlightened. "That's a great point. I think I'll do that, Hammurabi."

"Hahaha." Hammurabi laughed lightly. "I'm just glad my simple-minded words could be of some minor help to you. I've one foot in the grave, but if my knowledge can help the younger generation, I must offer it wherever possible."

"Don't even say such silly things!" Mandy laughed. "I'm always happy to talk with you! I wish I could do it more often."

"You just stick to your research, and I'll pop over once in a while to make sure you haven't dried up from a lack of water." Hammurabi concluded.

He stood up to go, but paused before leaving.

"Ah... there is one other thing I wished to discuss with you."

Seeing the serious look on Hammurabi's face, Mandy stood up as well. "Yes?"

"This is... rather awkward to mention. I also feel the timing is rather in poor taste..." Hammurabi said hesitantly. "But I feel it must be said."

"It's fine. Just speak your mind." Mandy replied.

Hammurabi smiled, but the expression felt a little forced. "Well, I've spoken to Levi about this as well. But, essentially, I think you, Levi, and maybe even Blake should be thinking about marriage. Not to one another of course, but to someone... *anyone* really, from among the humans in Realspace."

Mandy blinked. She really didn't expect this line of discussion.

"M-marriage? Why?" Mandy asked, giving Hammurabi a strange look.

"There is no easy way to say this." Hammurabi said. "You and your brothers are special. For some reason, the Heroic Aura has clearly passed down to you from your father. All of you are incredibly powerful Heroes in your own right, and you three are all somehow Trueborns. Your father sired three children before he passed. I think it is important, critically important even, that you consider expanding on his lineage as soon as possible."

Hammurabi continued. "Do not look down on this matter. I was unable to sire children possessing the Heroic spirit, but even I took multiple wives, and they bore me

three sons and a daughter. If those children had possessed a fraction of your power, I would have leaped over the moon in exultation!"

Mandy's frown eased up. With her sharp tactical mind, she was easily able to parse the logic in his words.

"You're right. And with humanity's Flaw removed, all humans theoretically have the power to become Trueborn Heroes. While it's not clear why nobody has obtained any heroic abilities yet, every shred of information we possess indicates they should rapidly begin ascending any day now. That means I really can't go wrong, no matter who I choose to be my husband..."

"Ah, haha..." Hammurabi chuckled weakly. "When I spoke of this matter to Levi, he seemed quite enraged I would 'dictate his private life' to him. I'm glad you understand the seriousness of what I am saying. Blake is quite young, but your father was the same age when he met Amelia. Jason was even younger when he wedded Phoebe. In these trying times, if bearing children can grant humanity an explosion of power, should we not do so as much as possible?"

Mandy nodded. "I am not too familiar with courting rituals or... um... wooing the opposite sex. I don't know how good I would do at it..."

"Hah! You are not the one who courts, silly girl!" Hammurabi laughed. "You are truly an antisocial shut-in. As a beautiful woman, it is the duty of men to prove themselves worthy for YOU! If I were to spread the word that you were looking for a partner, I fear the rabid men of the outside world would beat down the doors to catch a glance of your face!"

"Do you need to make the process sound so utterly terrifying?" Mandy half-joked. "But fine, fine, I get the idea. More children, more Trueborn, more power for humanity. I hadn't really considered dating or marriage, but I certainly see the value in it. When humanity absorbs Sharmur and Pixiv, I will visit the Fairies to see if they can help me make a breakthrough in my Mindverse, and then I shall visit Sharmur to see if there are any notable suitors appropriate for my status."

Hammurabi rolled his eyes. "Listen to you, already speaking like a noble princess passing judgment on the unworthy! You know romance is supposed to be quite fun and breathtaking, don't you? Don't treat this as another task to check off a list, or you'll end up

in a loveless marriage where all you do is pop out babies while feeling unsatisfied your entire life."

Mandy shrugged. She didn't seem to understand any of the appeal of 'romance', so in her eyes Hammurabi was acting silly. To her, it truly just was something that was her duty. She had no real interest in romance whatsoever.

"I'll look into it if I have time." Mandy said dismissively. "Was there anything else?"

Hammurabi hesitated. "I could look into suitors for you-"

"No, no, you don't need to go that far for me." Mandy said with a smile. "I'll figure it out when the time is right."

Hammurabi was helpless. He pressed his palms together and bowed as a farewell, then he strode out of the room while rubbing his face. He grimaced once her library was far behind him.

"That girl is usually so brilliant, but when it comes to matters of love, she's as dense as a rock. I imagine she would have melted into a puddle of embarrassment if I deliberately mentioned copulation or anything else of the sort. I fear that without external help, she'll remain single for the rest of her life. Let's hope her brothers have more charisma and interest in the opposite sex..."

Oblivious to her ancestor's thoughts, Mandy felt her spirits lifted, and she returned to her work on the Mindverse with greater gusto than before.

"Now that I think about it, perhaps I've been going about all this wrong. What if I purged all the Runes I've etched on myself and started from scratch? I should try to simulate the birth of a universe, and to let the Mindverse develop naturally on its own. I think this path has a lot more potential than laboriously creating a world myself! Hmm... but all these years of work I've put into my personal Runes... do I truly wish to throw them away?"

Mandy fell deep into thought. She would need much more time before she could make a decision about starting over from scratch, and her fear of the consequences would ensure she'd need to test her theories before she could put them into practice.

"There's no getting around it. I'll have to talk to the Fairies before I make any concrete decisions." Mandy decided.

Nobody in existence had any idea just how important her work would become in the following years. Perhaps only her closest mentor, Solomon, would have understood. But with his passing, Mandy had been left truly alone in the universe. Not even her closest family members had the capacity to understand the true value of her magic.

Someday, that would change.

Part 734: One Last Goodbye

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Somewhere in the Labyrinth…

Abby, the Baron of Happy Thoughts, held an odd glowing rectangle in her hands. She stood in the Oracle Hive, where she had spent much of her life, and chatted casually with several of her friends. Abby had once been an Oracle, a long time ago when she was still a Demon Grunt, but after becoming a Lord and then a Baron, she moved on to greater things, mainly spending time working with Ose during the Energy Wars, only to return to the Oracles after the destruction of Earth.

One hundred thousand years was a long time. Abby had developed all sorts of friendly and professional relationships with the other demons working inside the Oracle Hive. Since Abby was also a succubus, she had a unique development cycle that had her functioning as a dual-grunt in her early years, though she always tended to focus on her Oracle work. Part of that was no doubt due to her obsession with Ose, who detested succubi, and who subtly made Abby want to reject that part of herself.

Giant blue crystals hung in the air. On each crystal, between one and four Oracles sat cross legged, their palms in their laps as they deduced potential future trends. Unlike certain individuals who could clearly see the future, Oracles were essentially attempting to predict important trends to divine future information in a more broad sense, rather than specific actions.

The room was constantly buzzing with blue light. Some of the Oracles were more powerful than the others, and they were capable of deciphering deeper trends, even occasionally predicting specific future threats days or even weeks ahead of time. Those special Oracles were the ones who obtained an entire Portent Crystal for themselves, while the lesser Oracles needed to share a single crystal among each other.

Abby held up the glowing rectangle, which displayed words and images on its front. This was an advanced device given to her by ADAM, which he had helpfully explained was known as a 'datapad.' On it, various information was displayed, including a listing of recent additions to the Garden of Eden, new robot types that were being built and developed, and new magical tools and weapons designed by Camael.

A tall male demon with gray skin and front-facing curved horns stood before Abby, his hands folded behind his back. He wore simple black robes that covered his torso and legs, with a hood left hanging behind himself, his head uncovered. Despite the fact that he stood a full foot taller than her, he was merely a Demon Grunt, an ordinary Oracle, and a Satyr at that. He did not dare to be rude to Abby, a bonafide Demon Baron, who outranked him by two entire levels.

"We could use your help with this matter." The Satyr said, his expression stern. "You are our best Oracle. Even if you've moved on to greener pastures, your abilities remain potent."

"I just think it's a waste of time!" Abby exclaimed, rolling her eyes. "I'm doing important stuff now, Genos."

"I understand that." Genos said. "But while Uriel was once our greatest enemy, she now could become a pillar of demonkind's strength. At least, according to Barbatos. We have to find her location. It might be possible to rescue her, assuming she has not fallen into the Kolvaxian's clutches."

Abby looked up from the datapad. "Look, Genos, I've told you guys a bunch of times. Just because I used to be an Oracle doesn't mean I want to be one forever. I have a much more important mission now than hunting down some Archangel who might be our enemy, or who might be our ally! My mission was given to me by Ose, and anything my precious Ose says, overrides anything you say. Got it?!"

Genos looked troubled. "I would not dare to presume, but... what could be more important than securing the power of a High Cosmic for our people? Barbatos alone does not give us enough assurances against the Kolvaxian menace."

Abby sighed. "I don't even know where to begin. I promised Ose I wouldn't spill the beans, okay? But let's just say she didn't sit on her butt for 100,000 years lounging around drinking blood wine! She was out there building a stockpile of weapons to help demonkind someday rule the galaxy! So trust me, working on Ose's project is way more important than hunting for Uriel. Maybe you guys should ask the Deities if they can advance some of you to Lord or even Baron! Then you won't need my help."

"We cannot spare the souls anymore, since demons are no longer allowed to reap human souls..." Genos said, his expression pained. "But if you truly do not wish to help us, I guess there's no helping it. We'll have to make do on our own."

"There you go! That's the spirit, big guy!" Abby laughed, lightly reaching out to clap his arm. "Anyway, I'm done here. Just wanted to pay you guys a visit and see what was up! I've gotta head back now!"

She turned to leave, but then Genos cleared his throat.

"Ahem, say, Abby? You keep mentioning Ose... but isn't she... dead?"

Abby paused. With her back to Genos, she didn't say anything for a moment.

"Yeah. She's technically dead." Abby said quietly. "But a part of her still lives on in spirit. And that's enough for me."

Genos scratched his head. He didn't really understand what Abby meant, but it wasn't his place to pry.

"Alright. Take care then, Baron of Happy Thoughts."

Abby nodded without looking back at him. She continued to walk forward, leaving the blue-lit Oracle Hive behind. Its light quickly grew fainter and fainter until she could not sense it anymore.

Abby walked for a while. A long while.

The route back to the hidden alcove that would teleport her to the Garden of Eden was not a short one. Unlike Ose, who could manipulate her Astral Form to rapidly fly through the walls of the Labyrinth, Abby had to walk or run through it the old fashioned way. She did transit across the Labyrinth a little faster by going to specific Warper hubs, but moving hundreds and hundreds of miles quickly was not easy for anyone to do, especially in the context of a winding three dimensional path that was constantly changing.

"The Labyrinth is so annoying." Abby muttered to herself. "Lots of living space, but such a pain in the butt to go anywhere."

Abby walked past various pod-shaped Birthing Rooms where Broodmothers labored to produce new Demon Imps, as well as a few Pleasure Pits where demons engaged in rancorous sex, violence, and other debauchery. Abby had even spent time in similar places in her youth, before she decided to become an Oracle full-time, but she wouldn't ever go there now. She transited through three separate Warper Stations before reaching the final stretch of her journey after six long grueling hours.

Abby's feet were starting to hurt. She wore white sneakers, and even so, her feet were still aching a little from all the running around.

Abby wasn't exactly a fashionista, but she had a certain look to her. She always kept her white hair up in a ponytail, she wore a punk rock T-shirt, and she preferred to let her succubus tail poke out of the back of her booty-shorts. Her entire outfit was black, except for her white socks and sneakers, and she had all sorts of skull decorations on her clothes as well.

Funnily enough, Abby's hair was not naturally white. It was originally black, but when she first met Ose more than 100,000 years ago, she'd become Ose's biggest fangirl and dyed her hair to match. Naturally, Ose rolled her eyes, but Abby didn't care. There was nobody in the universe she thought about more than Ose... especially after Ose's death.

Even now, on the way back to the Garden of Eden, Abby bobbed her head from side to side as she thought about the tiny soul sliver of Ose that was inside Bael's Matriarch Armor.

Could there be a way for Abby to communicate with Ose? She had donned the Matriarch Armor in the past, but she wasn't able to hear Ose's voice. She didn't think Bael was lying, so he must truly be able to talk to her. It likely had something to do with the fact that Bael was now inhabiting Ose's original body.

While Abby was thinking these things, she suddenly came to a stop as a strange, cold feeling softly passed over her body. Abby flinched, then lifted her eyes to look into the distance.

Up ahead, Abby could just barely make out a figure that would scare the shit out of any other demon. The figure had two heads, four arms, and a body covered in glowing red eyeballs. He looked like a freak, an abomination, a monster that should not exist. But Abby had never perceived him as an enemy... not towards her.

"...Gressil?" Abby asked hesitantly, as she walked toward him.

She wasn't exactly scared, but the two of them weren't particularly close anymore. Ever since devouring Lucifer during the Energy Wars, Gressil had become something of a loner. Abby always felt pangs of sympathy for him, but he tended to avoid her, for reasons unknown. She wasn't sure if she had hurt his feelings in the past, or if maybe he was scared of hurting her, or maybe his personality had changed and he no longer considered her a friend.

But now he was here. In front of her. And his appearance didn't feel like a coincidence.

As Abby approached, she noticed Gressil's head was bowed, and he was leaning back against the corridor wall. He had a solemn, heavy expression on his face.

"Hello, Abby." Gressil said quietly. His voice was soft. Maybe even a little bit warm. But there was also a hint of melancholy to it. "It's been a while."

Abby stopped a short distance away. She nodded slowly. "Yeah, Gres. It's been a while. Um. How are... *you*?"

Gressil visibly seemed downcast, but Abby had no idea why. She decided to gently probe his mood.

"Not great." Gressil admitted. He still hadn't looked at her once. "Something happened recently. I lost a friend, and in his absence, I realized... I don't have many friends left."

Abby bobbed her head slightly. "So you're feeling lonely? And you wanted to come see me?"

Gressil was quiet for a time.

"Ose is dead." Gressil said. "The Wordsmiths are gone. A new Game is afoot. But I no longer have access to the Temporal Realm. After the Great Shattering, the future has lost its cohesion. And thus, so too have I become somewhat... lost."

Abby blinked. "Um... Temporal Realm... Great Shattering... I don't really get it, Gres. I know we haven't talked in a long time, but if you want to talk, I'm here now."

"That's good." Gressil said, finally turning his head to smile faintly at her. "Let's sit."

Abby nodded.

Gressil lowered himself to the ground, and Abby took the initiative to sit beside him, within arm's length. If he had any evil intentions, he could reach out and kill her on the spot. But Abby didn't think he would do that, and she had no reason to distrust him.

"So." Abby said quietly. "What's up with you, big guy?"

Gressil sighed. "I can't see the future anymore. It's thrilling, in a way, but I can vaguely sense a great loss approaching. Truth be told, I don't think you and I will be able to talk again after this. So... I wanted to speak to you, maybe for the last time."

"What? For the last time?!" Abby fried. "No, no, Gres, don't be silly. You're an Emperor now. Nothing's going to happen to you!"

"Emperors are not the powerhouses they used to be." Gressil said. "Deities are. And I am no Demon Deity."

Abby suddenly remembered something. "Say... I heard a rumor recently that Emperor Crow was killed. You weren't involved, were you?"

Gressil turned his head slightly to look at her. A long moment of silence followed.

"She targeted someone... precious to me. So I had to eliminate her."

"Is that the problem then? You're worried the Deities want you dead because you killed one of their own?" Abby pressed.

Gressil shrugged. "They definitely want me dead. But death is not the worst fate one can suffer. At least death is final, to some extent. They might instead wish to capture me, torment me, or other such things."

Gressil paused.

"But I didn't really come here to talk about myself. I wanted to see how you were doing. Have you been well, Abby?"

Abby started to affirm in the positive, but then she caught herself. A moment followed where she lowered her eyes and looked at the ground.

"...Not really, Gres. I haven't been doing so great myself. Ose died, and she meant a lot to me."

"I know she did." Gressil said. "She meant a lot to me as well. We had our differences, but ultimately, Ose was my sister... and I loved her. I simply didn't know how to show that love."

"Yeah..." Abby said softly. "You've always had it... rough."

After hesitating for a moment, Abby tentatively reached out and touched Gressil's hand. She smiled sheepishly at him, and he offered a rare smile back.

Gressil quietly took her hand in his.

The two of them sat there in silence, in the darkness of the Labyrinth, where their demonic vision had no trouble seeing.

Five long minutes passed.

"You know, Gres..." Abby said quietly. "I, um... I loved- I still love Ose. So much. So very much. But I want you to know I've always cared for you too. I'm sorry I pulled away

after... the incident."

"You were scared of what I'd become." Gressil said. "Your fear was only natural."

"No. No!" Abby exclaimed, looking at him in surprise. "That's not true at all, Gres! I was never scared of you, not then and not now. I know that you've done some horrible things, but I also know what sort of a person you really are!"

She paused.

"Gres, you're not a bad person. *You're not*. That... that *woman* hurt you. She beat you, insulted you, messed with your head. It turned you cruel. But that wasn't your fault. Your revenge was scary, but I understood it. I always did. When you changed, I avoided you because... because I didn't know how to process what had happened! Because I didn't know what to say to make you feel better! Because I *was* scared... of hurting you even more."

Abby turned her body, then reached up to touch Gressil's deformed, birdlike face, with its long beak and other misshapen features.

"I should have been there for you, Gres. I'm so sorry I wasn't a good friend."

Gressil reached his own hand up and gently pressed it against Abby's hand, now resting on his face. He gave her a long, sad look.

"You were right to avoid me." Gressil said. "I became a monster. I'm still a monster. If I had hurt you in my rage... I don't think I could have forgiven myself."

Gressil pulled her hand away, then released his hold on her other hand, putting a little distance between them.

"What happened in the past will remain in the past." Gressil said, looking forward at the opposite wall once more. "We cannot change the past. We can only move on from it."

"I guess you're right." Abby said, her expression gloomy. She sat back down and crossed her arms around her legs, resting her chin on her knees. "I still feel bad though."

Gressil reached over and rested a palm on Abby's back. "There's no need to feel that way. I'm glad I was able to call you my friend."

"Me too." Abby said, only to realize something, as she turned her head to look at him. "Wait, what do you mean 'was' able? We're still friends, Gres."

"Yes. But this is the last time we're going to speak." Gressil said. "I wanted to make sure our last meeting was a good one. I have to go now. We won't see each other again after this."

Abby blinked. Gressil was already standing up, which made her heart race with fright. She quickly jumped to her feet and grabbed his arm.

"Wait, wait! Gres! What do you mean? Where are you going? What are you planning?! Why won't I see you anymore?!"

Gressil looked down at Abby's small, frail hands that were not even able to properly wrap around the circumference of his arms. He was far larger than her. She was a small and dainty demoness, while he was a disfigured monster.

The distance between them had grown over time, and even now he could feel the chasm widening.

"There's no point telling you." Gressil said. "This is one future event that remains fixed. Because it's the choices we make that define us."

Abby's chest tightened with emotion. She croaked out a few weak words, as tears started to well up in her eyes. Gressil gently pulled his arm away from her, then brushed away her tears.

"Goodbye, Abby. For the last time."

Abby's body shook. She started to reach out, to try and grab onto Gressil so he couldn't leave, but she was a second too slow. Gressil's form turned immaterial as he faded away, his aura vanishing from the hallway.

"Wait! WAIT! Gressil, no! Stop! Whatever you're about to do, don't do it! Gressil? GRESSIL?! Do you hear me? Come back, big guy! Come back, Gres! I mean it, I'm not kidding around!"

"Gres!"

"GRESSIL!!"

The strength left Abby's legs. She fell to her knees and started to sob, not even certain what was about to happen, but confident it was going to be very, very bad.

"Gressil... Gres... no, devils... I can't lose them both... I can't lose him too..."

Abby wept. At this moment, she became a ball of emotions, unable to stop herself from experiencing a sensation of loss just as acute as when Ose died.

She knew she could not persuade Gressil to stop whatever he was about to do, and even if she could, she had no way of tracking him down! Gressil was the most elusive demon in all the Seven Hells.

Thus, she lost her rationality and sobbed, cried, and wept for a full hour.

Time passed.

Eventually, her tears ran their course. Abby shakily stood up and started staggering forward, her eyes hollow as she made her way back to the portal which would take her to the Garden of Eden. She found the secret wall panel, then stepped inside of it. ADAM was already waiting for her there. Without a word, the two of them disappeared, traveling to a place somewhere unknown in the galaxy, where Ose's secret base of operations had been built.

When Abby arrived, her body language was downcast beyond all reason. Nobody had ever seen the usually bright, bubbly Baron of Happy Thoughts in such a state of complete depression. She looked as if her entire life had fallen apart and she had no idea what to do about it.

Abby sat down inside the small cafeteria. The shiny, slick, white colored tables were spotless as always, just like how Ose liked them. Servant bots came to ask if she was hungry, but Abby simply shook her head, her body numb from sadness.

Eventually, Bael wandered over, having been informed of Abby's return by ADAM.

"Hey, girl! What's up? You uh... you good, sister?"

Bael plunked down on the bench beside Abby. She didn't answer him, but instead opted to hollowly stare at the table, unblinking.

"Abby? Aaaaabby? What's goin' on? You alright? Wanna talk about it?" Bael pestered. He could tell something was wrong, but Bael was hardly one for nuance. He was a lunkhead, through and through.

Abby slowly blinked. She turned to look at Bael, her eyes puffy and red from all her crying. "Huh...? Wha... what was that, Bael?"

Bael gulped. "Hey, honey. You uh, you don't look so good. You wanna talk?"

Abby nodded dumbly, her expression blank. "Yeah... no... yeah... I don't know. I just... I want a hug, Bael."

Bael's eyes softened. "A hug? Sure. Everyone needs a good hug once in a while. C'mere."

He reached his arms out, and Abby immediately leaned forward into his embrace. She wrapped her arms around his back and sighed as her head rested against his plump breasts.

"Hey Bael... let's... not talk for a while... okay? No talk."

"Okay." Bael said, as he gently rubbed her back. "No talking."

Abby closed her eyes. She imagined that she was not hugging Bael, but Ose. It was Ose's body, after all. It was almost as if Ose was still there, in body if not in spirit.

Ose... I miss you so much. Now Gressil's going away too... I don't want to be alone. I wish that Wordsmith had never appeared. I wish none of this had ever happened. I was happy with the way things were.

Abby choked back a sob.

I wish I could have loved you the way you deserved. I wish I could have been there for Gres. I wish I had been a better friend...

Inside the Matriarch Armor, Ose awakened. Her soul sliver was still contained within Bael's belt, the object known as Mjölnir. As such, she was able to perceive the world around her.

[Hmm?] Ose muttered to herself. [Something's off about Abby. She's not usually like this. I wish I could speak to her so I could find out what happened.]

Just as the thought came to Ose, her spiritual body jolted with shock.

[What? What's this?! Impossible... a faint soul resonance...?! Why am I able to sense Abby's soul? My spirit should not be strong enough to do that, which means... the situation has changed? Has Abby herself changed?]

Ose thought long and hard as Abby remained in Bael's embrace.

A spark of light flickered inside the crafty Emperor's eyes. [I sense that a possibility which didn't exist before might be doable now. This could be... a chance!]

Part 735: Genetic Manipulation

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. The Garden of Eden.

Abby was in a miserable state, but hugging Bael improved her mood quite a bit. After five or ten minutes of him gently rubbing and patting her back in silence, she eventually pulled away and wiped her eyes.

"Th-thanks, Bael. I'm sorry I got so weepy." Abby mumbled.

"It's fine, honey." Bael said, smiling at her. "You wanna talk about it?"

Abby thought for a moment, then shook her head. "No... not really."

"Oh. Okay." Bael said.

After a minute, Bael scratched the back of his head.

"So, uh, did you do that thing Ose wanted?"

The Baron of Happy Thoughts blinked. She thought for a moment. "Oh... yeah. I got in touch with them."

She reached into a pocket on the side of her booty shorts, where she'd stuffed the datapad from earlier. She mumbled something to herself as she took a minute to login to the device. She wasn't good with technology at all, but in order to follow in Ose's footsteps, she had been putting in real effort to try and learn.

After running three different biometric scans to validate her identity, Abby started scrolling down the list on the datapad.

"Um, I contacted Laharl. She didn't seem too interested at first, but when I explained to her that becoming a Duke or an Emperor wasn't viable in the long term due to a soul shortage, she bit. She has the um... the skillset we need too."

Abby sniffled. She wiped her nose, trying to refocus her thoughts away from what Gressil told her before.

"Then I um... I looked for Vepar. It turns out she's already a Deity now, so... looks like our info is out of date."

"Vepar is? Man, guess I've been on this planet too long." Bael mumbled. "Shit, it's only been a couple of days since I last saw her."

"A little longer than that..." Abby said, before remembering Bael didn't know how to count. "Uh, who else? Oh, I found Orias! He's exactly the type of demon we want, but... he wasn't interested."

Bael nodded. "That's a shame."

"Several of the Dukes from the Hell of Lust seemed interested." Abby said. "But um... they said they were going to stay with the humans."

"Typical." Bael grunted. "Those sex-pests've always gotta stick around with humans."

Abby scrolled her eyes down the list of names. There weren't many left.

"So yeah... that's it." She said eventually. "Just Laharl. She was the only one who fit Ose's qualifications. I found plenty of Grunts and a few Lords, but thanks to Glinch's pills, most demons have been split between Emperors or stronger and Lords or weaker. The Seven Hells don't have a lot of Barons left, and not too many Dukes either."

Bael fell silent for a moment. He seemed to be listening to something.

"Mmm. Ose says that'll have to do. You did the best you could. Her gadgets would work better if we could throw 'em on Barons and Dukes who focus on physical combat, but Lords and Grunts can get boosted just fine, too."

It turned out the reason Abby had gone into the Labyrinth was because Ose was finally planning to equip her technological upgrades on other demons. She needed demons willing to experiment with this technology, but unfortunately, the number of demons these days who were most compatible with her equipment was painfully small.

In Ose's ideal world, her armor suits and weapons would augment the strengths of Demon Barons and Dukes better than any other class of demons. Demon Emperors were already strong enough that the equipment would provide a negligible boost, while Grunts and Lords were a little too weak, unable to use the armor to its fullest extent.

Of course, anyone at or below the Baron level would get a tremendous boost to their combat capabilities, but Barons were the target audience since their strength could be directly raised to levels comparable to Demon Emperors. Lords would only become as strong as Dukes, and Grunts might barely reach the level of Barons.

For Demon Dukes, they would also be raised to the level of Emperors, but Emperors didn't have a lot of headroom for their own increase. Thus, the new technology would be wasted on them.

Unfortunately, due to Glinch's pills, countless Demon Barons and Dukes had been uplifted to the level of Emperor, and many Emperors had been raised to Deity by Diablo before his unfortunate death. This would normally be great news, but for Ose, it couldn't have come at a worse time.

No doubt, she was silently cursing her luck inside Bael's belt, but if she was, Abby couldn't hear it.

"I'm sorry." Abby said sullenly. "There's still plenty of strong Lords out there..."

Bael didn't even bother speaking Ose's next words. He just smiled and squeezed Abby's shoulder reassuringly. "Seriously, it ain't your fault, sister. We'll do fine with Lords 'n Grunts."

After a minute, Bael scratched his head. He looked off to the side.

"Huh. Really?" Bael asked.

Abby looked at him. It was obvious he was talking to Ose.

"What did she say?" Abby asked, looking wistfully at the belt that contained Ose's soul shard.

Bael looked back at Abby. "Uh, I don't really get it. Ose said she sensed a thing from you earlier. Wanted to test it out."

"A thing?" Abby repeated.

"Ye." Bael said, giving her a goofy thumbs up. "A soul thing. A soul... redderbence. Uh. Rememberance. Soul roadkill. No? That ain't it either? Well for cryin' out loud, don't use such a big word then!"

Bael suddenly started shouting at the air angrily.

"Lady, it's YOUR stupid word! Not my fault you can't say it right."

"Now now, don't you go pointing fingers at me, missy!"

"Fine, I'll try again! Soul... redshift!"

"Seriously?! Lucifer's tits, why can't you just use an easier word then? No I don't give a shit if she's your mom, she had a nice rack! I missed lookin' at them triple-titties!"

Abby stared, her jaw slightly ajar, as Bael launched into a one-sided argument with Ose, an argument Abby wished she could fully hear. It was off-putting hearing him shout at the air.

"Um.. Bael..." Abby said quietly. "Did you mean to say... Soul Resonance?"

Bael spun to look at Abby. "Exactly! Soul Retarding! You got it, sister!"

Abby ignored his mispronunciation. "So, Ose said she sensed a resonance earlier?"

"Mhm. Yeah." Bael said, giving her another thumbs up. "She said she wanted to run a test with you."

"Okay! Let's try it, then!" Abby said with a smile.

It wasn't the first time they had done this. In fact, weeks before, Abby had pestered Ose constantly, hoping they would be able to find a soul resonance so that Abby would be able to talk to Ose. Unfortunately, she had failed over and over again. Eventually, Abby gave up, feeling sad and disappointed in herself.

But now, Ose's words gave her a renewed hope! Abby practically dragged Bael along to a certain test chamber in the Garden of Eden, where ADAM met up with them shortly after.

"**Another resonance test?**" Adam queried.

"Yeah!" Abby exclaimed. "This time, Ose said she sensed something!"

ADAM glanced at Bael who nodded in response. "That's all she told me, Add-Dumb."

The Protectorate acknowledged their command without speaking any words. ADAM gestured to Abby, and Bael unbuckled Mjolnir's belt from his body. He passed it over to Abby, who quickly put it on, then walked over to a cylindrical glass tube placed on top of a machine of some sort. The tube lifted up, Abby walked underneath it, and it closed down on top of her, sealing her inside.

"Please, please, please..." Abby whispered, closing her eyes and crossing her fingers as a look of hope mixed with fear played upon her face. "Don't tease me. Let this be the one..."

A glowing blood-red demonic rune activated underneath Abby's feet. Soon, a tingling sensation began to activate within her body. She shivered, not from the cold, but from her nerves, as her toes and fingers started to hurt a little. Waves of electrical energy surged through her body over the next five minutes, making her feel as if her body had gone numb, and now she was standing on pins and needles.

Abby gritted her teeth even harder. She rubbed her arms and winced as the pain grew more intense than before. It was far from unbearable, but it wasn't pleasant, either.

Eventually, the feeling died down, and ADAM turned off the device. The robot's expressionless head turned to look at her.

"**I have detected a resonance.**" ADAM said without any fanfare. "**Previously, your Synchronization range fell between 0.35% and 1.11%; within the margin of error. Now, however, your Synchronization has risen to a range between 10.91% and 17.31%. This range is far higher than before, and it appears to be growing.**"

Abby looked at him, slightly dumbstruck, not quite able to comprehend the robot's words.

"So, that means..."

"**I have adjusted Master Ose's soul frequency window. You should be able to communicate with her now.**" ADAM said.

For a brief moment, Abby's heart nearly stopped. She felt a wave of disbelief sweep over her as she looked down at the belt.

"Os... Ose? Is that true? Can we speak to one another now?"

For a moment, nothing happened. But then, a faint phantasm appeared inside Abby's field of view. She instantly knew the person she was seeing was Ose, but Ose's physical features were extremely faint and difficult to make out.

[I believe so.] Ose said, her voice not exactly crisp and clear, but certainly audible. It sounded somewhat muffled, as if she were speaking through a tube made of cardboard, but to Abby, it was the most glorious sound she had heard in a long time. [Can you hear me, Abby?]

"Hear you... hear you..." Abby said, her mind in a daze. "Y-yes. YES! I can- I can HEAR YOU, Ose!! EEEEEEEE!!! Ohmygosh it's you! It's really you! Ohmygosh ohmygosh!!!"

Abby started babbling excitedly. Ose's expression turned to a grimace, but she could only sigh and massage her eyelids tiredly. [Well. At least it's better than being stuck talking to that other idiot.]

"Ose! Ohmygosh I can't believe it! You're back! I had my doubts sometimes but now I can see it's really you!!" Abby cheered, her spirits rising to the heavens. "We're gonna

have so much fun now! We're gonna play games, and have girls nights out, and-"

[Abby!] Ose shouted, snapping Abby out of her babble-streak. [Focus. Calm down. It's nice to talk to you, too. Okay? But let us descend from the clouds to the real world.]

Abby snapped her mouth closed. She nodded up and down in big, broad movements, beaming the happiest smile of her life. She simply couldn't stop grinning now that she had the chance to talk to her idol, the woman she loved, once again.

With Abby finally shutting up, Ose managed to slow down the tempo of the conversation. She took a minute to collect herself, then pressed her palms together, resting her fingertips against her nose. Her expression became contemplative.

[Bael is an idiot. I've been trapped in his mind, unable to change the world because he doesn't know how to follow basic commands. But you're smart enough that you can understand technology at a basic level and properly relay my words to ADAM and the others. Isn't that right?]

Abby nodded. "I can do that!"

[Good. But there's another reason to be excited. Bael's soul is too powerful. I have no way of getting back into my old body. But *you* are only a Baron. I can get out of this belt and share a mental space with you, and together we can swap control of your body once in a while. By doing this, I can directly affect the real world and start my work back up once more!]

Abby's eyes widened. "Is that... possible? I can have you in my head?"

[I'll need to increase the resonance further, but yes. It's definitely doable. I long ago made preparations to revive in the event of my body's death. Unfortunately, I did not anticipate Bael's soul being so powerful. But in essence, transferring my soul into your body so we can share a space isn't difficult now. We've already gotten past the hardest part.]

Ose elaborated further, hitting Abby with a barrage of technical information. Abby was a lot smarter than Bael, but that wasn't saying much. She wasn't a technomancer, and that meant many of Ose's theories flew over her head.

"Whatever." Abby said eventually. "I trust you, Ose. If you think it will work, then let's do it! You can control my body any time you want! I'm happy to share it with you! Really!"

[If you're truly okay with it, then we can initiate the transfer right here.] Ose said. [This unit is a multi-purpose Soul Resonance Alteration Device. I designed the SRAD to help me find a new host in the event of my death, and transfer my soul into it. Unfortunately, I ended up stuck with Bael for longer than intended. But... that's in the past now.]

At Ose's recommendation, Abby asked ADAM to initiate the transference. Unfortunately, the resonance rating was a little too low, so ADAM had to first alter Abby's body using the SRAD's genetic configuration settings.

Pulses of electricity surged through Abby's body, making her wince in pain. This time, the pain was much more acute. Reconfiguring her biology wasn't possible before, as she and Ose had zero compatibility, but now that ADAM could use the limited resonance frequencies to find a 'target lock' on certain genetic markers, the transition become much more doable.

Abby whimpered quietly. She fell to her knees and hugged her arms against her chest, sweating profusely as she rested her head against the inside of the SRAD's glass tube.

All the while, Bael watched, a frown stuck to his face.

"Hey, Add-Dumb." Bael grunted, shuffling closer to the robot. "This zappy thing looks like it hurts. Is it safe?"

ADAM responded in the affirmative. "**A certain amount of discomfort and pain is to be expected. I need to reconfigure Abby's genetic markers to ensure proper sequencing for Ose's soul transference.**"

Bael nodded. "Mmm, I see. Got it."

Bael leaned away from ADAM, nodding solemnly to himself. He had absolutely no idea what the Protectorate had said, but he wisely knew not to say too much, otherwise people might think he was an idiot or something.

Minutes passed. Soon, a full hour had come and gone. Abby was exhausted. The pain never seemed to end. She wavered in and out of consciousness, and had eventually slumped against the inside of the glass. The pain was severe, though nowhere near her limits. Her biggest issue was that it was a constant pain that changed all the time, affecting different parts of her body. Her DNA was being overwritten, which had no affect on her appearance, but did have all sorts of implications regarding her internal biology.

Soon, ADAM completed its work. The Protectorate dialed the system to a stop, and Abby nearly fainted from joy that the pain was finally over. She breathed heavily, her exhales coming in the form of ragged gasps.

"It's... ohh... it's done?" Abby wheezed.

ADAM bobbed its head. "**The genetic transformation is complete. According to my readings, your soul resonance has risen to a range between 77.89% and 97.44%. While imperfect, this level is within the acceptable range for a soul transference.**"

Abby's eyes lolled to the left. Kneeling on one leg beside her, she saw Ose's face for the first time. Not a vague apparition, but a genuine, physical-looking spirit-body of Ose where she could make out all the details of her favorite outfit, all the curves and lines of her face, and her yellow and red eyes.

[Abby.] Ose said, reaching out to touch Abby's face. Her hand failed to make contact. [Are you alright? I'm sorry you had to suffer for me.]

Ose's voice was warm and kind. It was unlike her usual self. But Abby could tell she was genuinely concerned for her friend's well-being.

The Baron of Happy Thoughts shuddered. She forced herself to turn around and sit on her butt with her back against the glass.

"I'm... I'm fine, Ose. Just a little bit tired. That's all."

Abby wanted to cry all over again. She was so happy to see Ose's face, she could barely contain her emotions. At the same time, she was exhausted, and even just crying would take too much out of her.

"Let's stop here." Ose said, her voice soft. "You've endured well. We can finish tomorrow."

Abby's breath caught in her throat. "What? No. No, we've waited long enough. Let's just... get it done now, Ose. Transfer into my mind. Then I can rest afterward."

Ose hesitated. "That would be... a little dangerous. You need time to rest."

Abby grunted. She raised her right hand and shook the feeling of numbness out of it. Then, through sheer force of will, she scooted backward, carefully standing up by leaning her entire body against the glass. Her legs were wobbly like Jello. Her consciousness wavered in and out, but eventually, she recovered thanks to her demonic physiology.

"I'm fine." Abby said, surprising both Ose and herself with the force behind her words. "How long will the transfer take?"

Ose paused. "Not long. A minute or less."

"That's it? Great. Great!" Abby said, the excitement of what was about to happen powering her psyche up even further. Her posture straightened further, and her footing became more steady. She grinned, then cracked her neck. "I'm ready! ADAM! Do it! Merge me and Ose together!"

"**A short rest first would be advisable.**" ADAM said.

"I don't need rest. I'm fine, now!" Abby protested. "I'm tougher than I look. Just do it."

The Protectorate gave her a long, hard stare. Eventually, it nodded, then began to press some buttons.

"**Very well. Beginning Soul Transference now.**"

Another round of tingling began to crackle inside Abby's body. This time, it was a lot gentler than before. She braced herself for pain, but the process felt more energizing than anything else.

Ten seconds passed. Twenty seconds. Thirty...

Abby looked around, slightly nervous, but the pain didn't seem to be intensifying.

"Is this actually doing anything?" Abby muttered. "I don't feel any diff-"

Suddenly, a massive rush of energy surged from Abby's waist, through her belly, and rushed up into her head. It was as if she had fallen face-first into a freezing cold lake. Abby's mind immediately blanked out. She fell forward and collapsed onto the ground, unconscious.

"Huh?!" Bael gasped. "Whoa, whoa! What just happened?! Abby! Hey Abby, you okay?? Add-Dumb, is she okay?!"

The robot looked at Bael. "**Soul Transference complete. All vitals stable. It was only a minor shock to Abby's system. Her life signs are within acceptable levels.**"

Abby's eyes fluttered open. Her head swam with dizziness. She wavered in and out of consciousness. Ahead of her, she could see Ose laying on the ground, her spiritual body

also unconscious. At the same time as Abby started to wake up, so did Ose. The two of them met each other's gazes.

Abby was immediately starstruck. Ose now looked as clear as could be. She appeared ghostly, with a bit of a glowing aura to her figure, but she was so lifelike that Abby swore she could reach out and touch Ose's hand.

She tried, but failed. Her hand passed through Ose's hand without even the slightest sensation following.

"It... worked..." Abby said, smiling dreamily.

But Ose did not smile back. Her eyes fluttered open and shut.

[I'm... I'm sorry, Abby. I was... I was wrong.] Ose said, her voice hoarse.

"Didn't work?" Abby asked, her voice slurring. "What... didn't work?"

[My soul... it was too weak.] Ose said. [I overestimated myself. I'm sorry. I thought we could... be together. But I was wrong.]

Ose closed her eyes. Abby's heart jumped. She struggled to sit up, but she had no strength left in her body.

"O-Ose? Ose?? What's... ohh... what's wrong? What happened?"

Ose groaned. Her voice was fainter than before.

[Your soul. It's... devouring mine.] Ose mumbled. Her words were slurred. She was having difficulty speaking. [I can feel my... consciousness... wavering. I don't have long now.]

Ose smiled weakly.

[I'm sorry, Abby. I wasn't a good friend... to you. I used you. Now I'm paying the price. I wish... I wish I had been... kinder to you. This is going... to be... the last time we talk.]

Tears welled up in Abby's eyes. She reached out to touch Ose's hand again, but both their palms passed through one another.

"No... Ose..." Abby croaked. "There... has to be something. My soul... too strong? Maybe... I can weaken it?"

[You've done enough.] Ose said, her eyes now tightly closed. [The only way... if your soul was... depleted. But no. Don't. Don't do it. Not for me. I'm not worth it.]

Abby felt a flash of inspiration.

"You said... my soul... it's in the way, right? So if I... drain my soul away? You can live? You can take over my body?"

Ose didn't answer. Her spirit-body was slowly becoming more and more transparent. This caused Abby's heart to jump in alarm. She realized time was running out.

"Ose... Ose!! No, you can't die! Not again! Not again!"

Abby hesitated. She realized in this moment, she still had a chance to save Ose. But doing so would, undoubtedly, force her to pay the ultimate price.

Her hesitation barely lasted a single second. She scowled angrily as she hardened her heart.

"I won't let you die, Ose. *I won't*. It's fine if I die. I'm nobody special anyway. I just wish... I could have spent more time with you."

Abby stretched her arm out. She tried uselessly to touch Ose's cheek, but as before, she failed once again.

A tear slid down Abby's face.

"Ose... I love you. I love you so much..."

Abby closed her eyes. She focused on the sensation of her soul, where she sensed Ose's soul fragment, minute by comparison, floating not far away from it.

Abby gritted her teeth and scrunched her forehead muscles. With great pain, she began sending her soul energy into Ose's soul fragment. The effects were immediate and unmistakable.

Abby's sense of self began to diminish. She opened her eyes a fraction, watching as Ose's soul form became slightly more corporeal.

But at the same time, Abby's vision began to waver. The more soul energy she transferred, the weaker her grasp on reality became.

It was now, in these final moments, as death approached, that Abby's mind became remarkably clear.

She remembered her life. She remembered the first time she spoke to Ose. She remembered how they met, and the way she fell in love with Ose the moment she laid eyes on her.

It started out as a childish infatuation. But it continued for 100,000 years. It was a painful, one-sided love.

All along, she knew Ose never loved her, and probably never would.

But it didn't matter. Ose had said such kind words to her only moments earlier. Even if those words were sweet lies, they were the only thing Abby had ever wanted to hear.

Sometimes, sweet lies were far superior to painful truths.

Abby closed her eyes, one last time.

She remembered what Gressil had told her, just a few hours earlier.

So that's what he meant. Abby thought silently to herself. *He knew what was coming. Oh, Gressil... thank you... for being there for me.*

I'm glad we got to talk...

One... last...

Abby's consciousness faded away. Eventually, it disappeared entirely.

A long minute passed.

Abby's eyes eventually opened. She stood up, no longer pained in any way. Abby looked around the room and cracked her back, seemingly unharmed by all the events that had just transpired.

"Finally. She really made me drag it out." *Abby* said, her tone much more pointed than before. "ADAM, code Four-One-One-Seven-Six-Niner-Zeta-Alpha-March."

ADAM nodded. "**Welcome back, Master Ose. It appears the Soul Transference was a success.**"

The glass tube lifted, revealing the new owner of Abby's body.

Ose, the former Demon Emperor of Infiltration, had returned to the world of the living.

"Get me some proper clothes." Ose commanded. "I'll not be caught dead walking around in this awful getup."

"**Yes, Master Ose.**" ADAM replied.

Bael stared at Ose with a distant, haunted look.

"Hey... hey... what's going on? Where's Abby?"

Ose snorted. "Abby? Unfortunately, it seems she pushed herself too hard and passed away. Now I own her body."

"WHAT?!" Bael exclaimed, looking at Ose in horror. "No way! Not sweet little Abby! Ose, what the hell did you do?!"

The New Abby dramatically rolled her eyes. "Oh, don't get your panties in a twist, *body-thief*. Abby did all this willingly. I barely even had to manipulate her. She practically threw her life away at the drop of a hat for my sake. It's better this way. Sharing would have been *such* a pain, especially with her constantly yammering at me."

Bael's pupils twitched. He found himself rooted in place, horrified and unable to move, as Ose casually strolled out of the Soul Transference facility.

Ose had returned. And only one other person in the entire galaxy knew this unprecedented event had transpired.

Part 736: Two-Faced

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. The Garden of Eden.

Ose was in a good mood. An *exceptional* mood, even. She had a spring in her step and couldn't stop snapping her fingers in rhythm to some unknown tune in her head. After she left the Soul Transference room, she couldn't help but skip along giddily to her next destination with a silly grin on her face.

"Hee-hee, eyes to see with, hands to grasp the world around me, and feet capable of touching the ground. What's not to love about having a body? Even if it's a little weak, I'll be back to my peak condition in no time."

Ose momentarily thought that her attitude seemed a little too sunshine-and-rainbows compared to how she usually acted, but then again, who could blame her for being so happy? Only a day earlier she had thought she would be trapped listening to Bael run his mouth for the rest of eternity, but now she had regained life, along with a decently attractive female body instead of a disgusting, overweight male one.

Naturally, possessing Bael's body back in the day had amazing upsides. She obtained access to all of her original powers, plus Bael's nearly invincible physique, which made her obscenely powerful. But even so, a woman as proud of her finely maintained appearance as Ose was could never be happy if she was trapped in the body of a slovenly fat bastard like Bael. Had she continued to exist in it without dying, she undoubtedly would have started a rigorous weight loss and training regimen to slim down. Within a year or two, she would have become unrecognizable!

But that was all in the past. She possessed Abby's body now, which was not as amazing as her original body, but it was a fine alternative. Maybe someday Ose would be able to figure out how to trade souls with Bael to reacquire her original self. She would definitely laugh at his misfortune if he ended up being the one stuck in Abby's body instead of her. It would serve him right.

Ose paused her skipping. She waved her hand, then frowned. Her happy mood deflated visibly.

"Hmm. Come on, why isn't it working?" Ose muttered.

She tapped into her magical core, her inner power, and tried to conjure lightning, electricity, even a single spark of energy. But after making all sorts of motions with her hands and concentrating her mind for a full minute, she failed to produce any results.

Ose's mood turned ugly.

"...I see. It seems I truly have been crippled." Ose said, her expression dismal. "I cannot produce any electricity. I may have completely lost all of my original powers!"

A thought sprang to Ose's mind. She changed her course and trotted over to an out-of-the-way part of the Garden of Eden. It was an isolated area where 'prisoners' were held, though these prisoners didn't actually know they had been imprisoned.

Only Ose knew the true location of the Garden of Eden. Not even the robots inside the facility knew. She had taken every precaution to keep its location a secret. Abby might not have been the brightest, but she understood the Garden of Eden was buried deep beneath the surface of an unknown planet somewhere in the Milky Way. What neither she nor Bael knew was that this underground facility was far, far bigger than it seemed, and they already thought it was massive.

Ose stepped inside a special region known as Inner Zone 2. There were three of these zones, and each of them formed artificial terrariums where clueless monsters had been carefully relocated, their memories wiped, the creatures completely oblivious to the fact they were now living in an isolated world very different from where they had been born and raised.

Inner Zone 2 was designated the Goblin Terrarium. Here, obviously, Goblins lived and thrived, with an entire ecosystem of food ready for them to consume, dirt for them to dig, and burrows for them to sleep and live in. Goblins typically lived underground, digging burrows beneath the soil to raise their families, but they were perfectly capable of constructing homes and other abodes on the surface as well. Different tribes had different customs.

Ose stood atop a catwalk high in the sky, one that was cleverly hidden from view so that the Goblins a mile below wouldn't be able to see her. With her keen demonic vision, Ose was able to peer down and make out the individual hairs on each Goblin's head.

She watched as a small group of goblins carried around a stretcher made of bone and animal-skins. On this stretcher there was a dead animal's carcass, likely the feast they had just hunted and would soon bring home for their village to consume.

Ose, naturally, did not care about these Goblins in the slightest. She came here for one specific reason.

"I'm quite fortunate." Ose mused. "Abby didn't just eradicate her soul, she fed my soul sliver with hers, so I now possess the power of a Baron. It thus follows that if I don't have access to my powers anymore, I must possess hers!"

Ose knew plenty about Abby's abilities. They didn't seem too potent, but essentially Abby could influence the thoughts and emotions of other beings, feed them illusions, and deceive their minds. Personally, Ose thought Abby had always drastically undervalued her abilities and utilized them poorly. If those were Ose's new powers, then she was sure to make better use of them.

Ose stretched out her hands. She aimed at the group of Goblins below, and tapped into her magical core, frowning as she began to concentrate.

She concentrated...

And concentrated...

Then she concentrated some more...

Sweat built up on Ose's forehead. Invisible question marks popped up above her head.

"Strange. Very strange. Why can't I influence them? Am I misunderstanding how Abby's abilities work? No, I wouldn't make such an elementary mistake..."

For once in her life, Ose was truly baffled. She couldn't activate her abilities, and she couldn't activate Abby's. For thirty long minutes, she panted and groaned, made all sorts of weird movements with her hands, and even tapped into her inner self over and over. The most she succeeded in doing was stressing herself out and becoming fatigued... all while accomplishing none of her goals!

Eventually, she gave up.

Ose glowered at the Goblins down below before turning and storming out of the terrarium.

"Could it be? Have I become utterly powerless?" Ose wondered. "I'm still a Baron. I can sense magical energy within myself. But why can't I tap into it? Have my powers fused with Abby's? Have they rejected one another and now I need to do something else to activate them?"

The former Emperor of Infiltration pondered a great many possibilities. She thought of this and that, her mind wandering as she guessed randomly and not-so-randomly at times.

"Even if I have no powers, at least I'm alive. I'm still a genius among my peers, and not even a lack of powers will change that. But it is rather disappointing to think I've become somewhat *ordinary*."

Ose returned back to her original destination. She entered a secret room that Bael and Abby had never visited, one that was hidden behind a retractable wall somewhere on the northern end of the Garden of Eden's 59th level. Considering how massive the Garden of Eden was, and the fact that Abby and Bael weren't exactly the most inquisitive people, with Bael being more lazy than anything else, they had not explored even five percent of the Garden's interior.

Thus, not only did they not know about this location, but they did not know of all Ose's other hidden places, either. Ose had prepared this secret base over 100,000 years. Everything in the Garden of Eden served a purpose...

The wall slid open. A new room revealed itself, one that had a horde of monitors arranged in a giant circle, all of them attached to the walls, and a central control console to interface with these monitors. The room was not too dissimilar to Jason's Spynet Sphere in appearance or purpose...

Ose stepped inside, where ADAM was already waiting for her.

"**Master Ose.**" ADAM said, the robot's tone as emotionless as ever. "**I have brought the item.**"

ADAM held up its palm, and in its grasp, there was a black orb made of demonstone. Ose's eyebrows raised slightly, and a smile played upon her face.

"Hehe, ruling the First Hell for a while certainly had its perks." Ose chuckled to herself. "It's a good thing I always come prepared..."

She walked over and took the small demonstone orb out of ADAM's grasp. Ose held it for a moment and sighed nostalgically. Then she pressed her palm on the top of the orb and carefully rotated the top clockwise, and the bottom counter-clockwise.

Without much effort, the orb slowly opened up. Ose popped the top off to reveal that inside the orb, there were four black beads of different sizes. One was extremely small,

tinier than a marble. Another was a bit bigger. A third one was even bigger than that, and the fourth was quite large, easily three times the size of an average demon's eyeball.

These were Soul Orbs. Each one contained a certain number of souls within them. They were part of Ose's long term revival plan in the event she died. She had pilfered them from Mephisto through a series of cleverly engineered distractions several years earlier, well before Operation Stormbringer.

"Hahaha..." Ose chuckled to herself. "Looks like I won't be needing the first two. Thanks to Abby, I already possess the power of a Baron. I might even be able to pick a useful Grunt and uplift them to Baron if they serve my purposes well. But for now, there's no reason to hesitate. I can become an Emperor again!"

Ose immediately took the third soul orb and popped it in her mouth. It was quite large, and she could only swallow it with great difficulty. The process of it rolling down her throat into her belly was anything but pleasant, but she still relented. If she still possessed her original electrical abilities, she could have easily deadened her gag reflex or turned off her pain centers to make the swallowing process easier, but now she could only grimace and forcibly bear the pain.

BOOM!!!

Ose's aura erupted with majesty! In a single instant, she burst with power and leaped across the chasm separating Barons and Dukes, becoming a powerhouse once again!

Ose had to take a minute to steady herself. Once she was completely sure she was ready, she picked up the biggest soul orb and stared at it with a hint of worry.

"Imagine... imagine if the great Ose died here, all alone, choking to death on a damned Soul Orb. I'd rather the whole facility burned to ash, along with me, so nobody would ever hear such a shameful tale!"

Her pride was part of her bones. Ose couldn't bear the thought of being humiliated, so she forced herself to shove the absolutely massive Soul Orb into her mouth, gagging and choking as she slowly, painfully, and carefully forced it down her throat.

Ose's eyes watered. Snot spewed from her nose. For ten long seconds, her face turned blue. She really thought this might be the end of her story!

But, by massaging her throat and carefully pinching certain areas, she painfully forced the Soul Orb down, down, down into the depths of her gullet. Once it reached a certain

point, the orb rolled the rest of the way smoothly and entered her stomach. Ose coughed and gagged, tears pouring from her eyes as she pounded her chest. If any other demon were to walk in and see her, she might die of shame right then and there!

At once, her aura blasted into the heavens once again. Ose stood up and roared at the sky as she felt her body firmly tear down the barrier of Demon Emperor, all thanks to the power of a million condensed human souls.

She had done it!

She had not only returned to the living, but had become an Emperor again!

From this point on, Ose knew she would be able to continue writing the epic tale of her life! The universe's mysteries awaited her!

Ose almost wanted to cry tears of happiness! She wasn't the dumb blubbering baby type, but even so, her raw emotions were difficult to suppress. Strangely, she thought these were the sorts of emotions only Abby would possess, but given the circumstances, it was only fair Ose would be so overwhelmed with emotions. It wasn't as if it was impossible for her to let out a good cry or anything, she simply had never done it in her entire life.

Ose slumped to the floor. She breathed heavily, then chuckled darkly under her breath.

"An Emperor again. Hehehe... the universe is being too kind to me, truly. my fortune is rising all the time. I don't even have any damned Wordsmiths to get in my way anymore. They were the only ones who could oppose me."

Ose's eyes flashed with an ominous, bloody light. She swept her hair back with her hands, then shakily stood up with ADAM's assistance.

"Put the other two Soul Orbs back, and only come back after an hour or so." Ose ordered. "I need time to think."

"**Yes, Master Ose.**" ADAM said obediently. The robot took the demonstone orb away, sealing it up as the machine left.

The room fell silent. Ose walked over to the central control matrix, then stretched out her hands.

Several long seconds passed.

Ose frowned. She tried to activate the controls with her electrokinesis, as she had a million times before, but nothing happened.

"Still?" Ose muttered. "I thought maybe becoming an Emperor would return my powers. Don't tell me I've truly become powerless! That would be a laughable tragedy to say the least. A complete waste of my talents!"

Once again, she tried tapping into Abby's abilities. But this, too, proved a flop.

Ose gnashed her teeth.

"I have magic! I have powers! I sense them! Why can't I activate them? What the hell are my abilities? Don't tell me I have some new power I don't know about?"

When demons evolved from Imps to Grunts, their 'nature' became known. The title of 'Grunt' typically revealed the initial form of what powers a demon would later wield. Upon becoming a Lord, every demon would know for sure what their unique abilities entailed. Some were like Yardrat, who started as a Warper and rapidly became an Emperor and a Deity who could manipulate the most mind-blowing long-range portals ever, along with space itself.

Beelzebub had started off life as a Burner, which obviously foretold his future evolution into a master of flames.

But, at the same time, not all demonic evolutions made sense. Abby was a succubus, but also an Oracle. Then when she became a Lord and a Baron, she learned she could manipulate emotions... this seemed to be a mixture of her succubus physiology and her Oracle powers.

And what about demons like Orias? He was a unique sort of demon who could use gems and other rare rocks to empower his body and gain new abilities temporarily. But unlike many demons, he had skipped straight from Imp to Baron due to the effect of the ancient dragon, Leviathan. Similar things were true for Satan, Belial, and other members of the ancient demons who had been directly elevated by Leviathan.

Even then, there were strange cases. Ose herself had been born an imp, then evolved into a 'demon child'. She had no powers, and just looked like a little girl. Demons like her were quite rare, but not unheard of. Beelzebub's former servant, Rosalia, was also a 'normal' demon, even as a Grunt.

Now, as Ose pondered the strangeness of her powers, she became more and more perplexed.

She and Abby had very different evolutionary trajectories. Ose felt that her powers now must be a fusion of the two, or a side-branch, but no matter what she tried, she couldn't come up with anything to explain her situation.

"Even if I have no powers, I still have the strength and physique of an Emperor." Ose said to herself. "I can still fight human war machines with my body alone. I'm still a faster thinker than when I was a Baron. I barely need any sleep, don't need food or water, and I'm immortal. It's not like my becoming an Emperor was a total waste!"

But these words merely served to soothe her ego. In truth, she was quite pissed. It felt unconscionable that she, the legendary Ose, was powerless now. It felt like the universe had slapped her across the face. She had always been a genius among her peers. Falling down to the level of an 'ordinary' Emperor ruffled the feathers of her ego.

Ose paced back and forth for a while. She tried all sorts of things, but time after time, she failed to uncover any new abilities.

Steam metaphorically spewed from Ose's ears. She squeezed her eyes shut and gritted her teeth. She widened her stance and flexed her arms, balling her hands into fists and she concentrated all her thoughts.

Come on! There must be something! There must be!! Ose thought.

Ose pressed her fingertips against the side of her head. She thought, she thought, and she thought some more. Her face turned even redder than its normal hue as she started to shake with desperation.

I... I can feel something! Ose grunted. *It's almost like-*

At that moment, the door to her Observation Chamber opened and ADAM strolled inside. "**Master Ose. I have returned-**" ADAM said, only to pause mid-sentence. "**...Master Ose?**"

Ose groaned. She opened her eyes to look at ADAM, but when she did, she suddenly felt extremely dizzy. Furthermore, it felt as if she were seeing double! There appeared to be two ADAMs staring back at her.

"What is it?!" Ose snapped. "Why are you bothering me? Huh?"

Ose jumped slightly. When she spoke, it sounded as if she heard herself speaking beside herself, on the right and on the left, but only out of one ear at a time. It was an extremely confusing, and disorienting, sensation.

Ose turned to her left.

"Huh?"

It was the strangest thing. Ose saw Abby in front of her, but only the back of her body. Except it wasn't Abby, it was Ose!

Ose was looking at Ose!

But, at the same time, Ose could also see the wall directly in front of herself as if she were looking past 'herself'.

"Huh??" Ose asked again, her tone more bewildered than before.

Ose turned to look to her right. When she did, she saw 'herself' turning around, and now she was looking at the back of her head again, as well as the center of the Observation Chamber.

Ose staggered slightly. She felt dizzy and confused. Her eyes blinked several times.

"What... what's going on with me?" Ose muttered. "Why am I seeing two... why am I hearing two of me?"

"**Master Ose.**" ADAM said. "**There are... currently two versions of you in this room.**"

"WHAT?!" Ose exclaimed, turning to look at ADAM once again. This time, she carefully focused her mind. She turned to look at 'herself', but the 'other her' also turned to look at 'herself'. They both made eye contact, and Ose's delirium worsened by another level. If felt as if she were looking into a mirror, one which distorted reality and broke her mind.

It was extremely confusing, disorienting, and it made no sense.

Yet she did it!

"You're me?" Ose asked, as both of her 'selves' spoke simultaneously. "You're a clone? No. You're me. I'm me? What's going on?"

A brief instant passed. Then, an idea came to Ose's mind. She carefully turned to the control system, then activated it using manual controls. There were cameras inside the

chamber, so Ose rewound one of the monitors to show the scene of just a few minutes before.

Before her, a miracle happened. While Ose was concentrating, a second version of herself slowly 'slid' out of her body and appeared behind her. Both of the two Oses were holding the same pose. Both of them then proceeded to mirror each other once ADAM entered the chamber.

For a brief moment, Ose felt slightly lost.

"Cloning...? I can clone myself?" She mused. "But it's so disorienting. I can see through both of my eyes at once. When I think, we share the exact same thoughts. It's like looking right and left at the same time. It feels... impossible."

Several minutes passed. Ose slowly began to experiment. It felt as if she were looking through a kaleidoscope, the way the world bent and shifted when each of her bodies moved. But slowly, as the minutes passed, she rapidly grew more and more proficient with controlling each of her two selves.

"This is... unexpected." Ose mumbled. "But far from bad. I would rather still possess my original abilities, but is this ability not intriguing in and of itself? It's certainly better than nothing!"

After a bit of work, Ose started controlling both bodies independently. One of them started doing squats while the other did jumping jacks. One of them read a book while the other one started reciting the digits of Pi.

"Amazing. Amazing!" Ose exclaimed. "I see. How interesting! I can control the flow of 'data' between us. I can choose how much to pilot and control each of the bodies versus letting them move and think autonomously. I can share our senses equally or focus more on one over the other. There's more nuance to this ability than I expected. I think I've barely begun to scratch the surface!"

Soon, the two Oses faced one another. They started sending slow punches and kicks at one another, then their fighting sped up.

Faster and faster, they started moving and thinking independently, all while still sharing brainwaves. A flurry of kicks and punches started striking one another as the clone tried to overpower the original body, except Ose no longer knew which was the original and which was the clone.

She didn't care, either!

This was a completely different situation from Jason and Hope Hiro. Unlike the foolish Wordsmith, whose other self was an independent entity, Ose had full control of both her selves. Even if she chose to split her perception directly in half, she could regain control instantly!

"Amazing. Truly incredible!" Ose praised after her fight session. "Even if someone tries to kill me again, I hypothesize they would need to kill both my bodies. It's like I've gained an additional life. And even more amazingly, neither of these two bodies is any weaker than when we were one. We're both Emperors, through and through!"

Soon, her thoughts dipped downward. Ose calmed herself and began to look at the big picture.

"If I can make two of me..."

"Then..."

"Could I create... *more*?"

An evil smile slowly stretched across her face...

Part 737: The Great Era

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. The world of Sharmur.

A tense atmosphere had descended upon humanity, especially the sixty percent of whom were currently located on the world of Sharmur. After Beelzebub's detonation, losses to the demons, the destruction of Tarus II, Kolvaxians, and other mass-casualty events, humanity had only about three million people left. And today was a moment that would drastically change their species' future trajectory.

That was because Camael's Cube had arrived inside the Sharmur System!

At long last, it had completed its journey. This was good news, because the reason the Cube had come here was to swallow all the worlds inside the system, as well as Sharmur's star, then place them inside the Cube for safekeeping. The Cube wasn't merely a massive secret dimension capable of traversing the cosmos in secret; it was also isolated from realspace, and virtually guaranteed whatever method the Kolvaxians used to arrive on planets would not work once a world had been moved into the Cube.

Even so, there was a risk.

What if there was secretly a single Kolvaxian, or even multiple of them, hiding beneath the surface of a planet? What if they deliberately concealed themselves? Could Uzziel use those hidden Kolvaxians to triangulate the Cube's inter-dimensional position and come up with a way to get inside?

Nobody knew. Not Melody, not the Phoenix herself, and certainly not the humans.

It was a big risk taking Sharmur into the Cube. The Phoenix was 100% certain that no Kolvaxians were presently inside the Cube, since all the worlds inside the Cube were fake worlds manufactured by the Wordsmith. However, these worlds were extremely flawed. While they could last indefinitely, the amount of raw matter present on the inner worlds was microscopic compared to a single planet the size of Earth, or the size of Sharmur.

To use a simple comparison, If Earth was a size scale of 1.0, and its moon, Luna, was a size 0.27 on that same scale, then each of these micro-worlds Jason had made for training human troopers were only 0.0002. They were truly tiny! Counted all together, they were probably the size of a country like the USA on Earth, but that was only when considering

the available flatlands. They had thin 'crusts' and atmospheres that only went a fraction of the distance into the sky compared to ancient Earth.

Thus, if the Phoenix did not bring in external worlds like Sharmur, then the arable and livable land inside the Cube would reach its max carrying capacity far too quickly.

Even worse, these micro-worlds were somewhat isolated from one another. Humans could travel between the worlds using the Phoenix's power, but her magic was limited in quantity, and transportation was not cheap on energy expenditure. It would be far better to use a great deal of energy to bring in multiple external worlds, then use those worlds to breed humans en-masse in order to harness their Faith Energy to refuel the Cube.

The Phoenix's wings were metaphorically tied. If she did not bring in worlds, the humans would quickly run out of living space, and she would run out of energy. If she brought in new worlds, this problem would be solved, but she would have to risk a potential Kolvaxian catastrophe.

Ultimately, the Phoenix came to a decision. She decided she would swallow the Sharmur system, not only to gain the resources she needed, but to hopefully add a Middle Cosmic powerhouse to her Cube as well. Then, she would do the same for the Pixiv system.

But after that, she would not risk placing any further worlds inside the Cube.

It wasn't that she lacked room for these worlds. Far from it! Camael's Cube possessed tens of lightyears worth of internal space. Counting all the residents and micro-worlds inside the Cube, she was using up far less than 1% of the available space, and once she moved in the Sharmur worlds and the Pixiv worlds... she would *still* be using far less than 1% of the available space!

The Phoenix knew she was taking a huge risk by transporting entire star systems inside the Cube. She was 99% sure she could pull it off one time without repercussions. However, the second time, which she planned to use on Pixiv, was a lot more dangerous. This was because the disappearance of an entire star system would definitely cause a noticeable spike in Cosmic energy throughout the galaxy. Even if there were no Kolvaxians in the Sharmur system, she might cause Raphael and Uzziel to take notice of her actions.

If that happened, the two of them might realize what the Phoenix's next destination was. They could quickly hide Kolvaxians somewhere inside the Pixiv system, be it on Pixiv

itself, or one of the other system worlds, and when the Phoenix swallowed that system, she would inadvertently poison the Cube's inner ecosystem.

But she was helpless regarding this matter. The Phoenix could choose to only bring Sharmur inside, which would be the safest option, but the fairy homeworld had a lot of humans too, and more importantly, the fairies possessed Formation Magic. This was extremely potent, and the Phoenix even knew a few ancient secrets about the fairies. She knew that allying with them would bring enormous future benefits to her pet humans, so long as they had time to develop.

All these considerations rumbled within the Phoenix's mind. Her wizened, aged eyes looked out from the Cube and passed through the Interdimensional Veil to peer into Realspace, where she locked gazes with her future ally.

[Demon Deity Melody.] The Phoenix said. [This ancient one is gladdened to make your acquaintance. I pray we can become good friends in the coming era.]

Melody was not on Sharmur at the moment, but had flown out into the Void. She sensed the approach of a powerful life form, but she could not pinpoint the Cube's location, only its faint emanations of energy.

[Sorry, Phoenix.] Melody apologized. [I'm a bit of a crude girl. Not as well-spoken as you. Are you going to move the system inside the Cube, one star at a time?]

The Phoenix sighed. [Such would be ideal, but it is not a good idea. Since your life force is tethered to these worlds, transporting one at a time could damage you internally, and perhaps even kill you. Instead, I shall spread out my Divine Sense throughout the whole system. Then, I will take all the worlds in at the same time, as well as yourself.]

[Need any help?] Melody asked.

The Phoenix thought for a moment. [This venerable's energy is limited. Swallowing this system will cause what reserves I still possess to plummet. If you could assist me in the transference process, I would be greatly appreciative.]

Melody frowned. [Not that I'm not willing, but... my Cosmic power's all tied up in Sharmur's star. If I use my power a shitload, won't it weaken the star?]

The Phoenix smiled. [Sharmur's star currently has 1.73 billion years left in its lifespan. If you were to fully fuel the transfer of the system yourself it would drop down to... 1.729 billion years.]

Melody blinked. [Oh. That ain't much of a dip.]

[No. It is not.] The Phoenix confirmed. [Stellar Orbs contain an incredible amount of current and future energy potential. More than many Apex Cosmics...]

After talking for a bit, the two Cosmics got to work. The Phoenix didn't dawdle any longer, as time was of the essence. She first investigated every planet in the system with her Divine Sense. Unlike Melody, who had barely been a Cosmic for a year, the Phoenix was hundreds of millions of years old, maybe even a billion or two. She was extremely learned in the ways of Cosmics, thus despite only having returned to power recently, she was just as sharp as during the ancient times.

Her powerful senses bored into each world, one by one by one. She used the heat of her eyes, the light of creation, to search for anomalous entities and life forms hiding away in each planet's crust and core.

After searching for a full hour, she found no Kolvaxians across any of the planets. Certainly, she found some odd life forms, alien fauna, most likely, but it seemed Diablo had done an excellent job when he took Sharmur back. He had completely wiped out the system's Kolvaxian infestations.

[You know,] Melody mentioned, [Diablo once told me the entire point of anchoring my presence to these stars was to create a 'spatial wall' that would prevent Kolvaxians from teleporting into the planet cores. If they even tried, I would know. At least, that's what he told me.]

The Phoenix nodded, though Melody could not see the motion. [This ancient one can sense your life force within each planet's core. This is truly an astounding innovation. For those who truly seek Cosmic Ascension, this method of uplifting oneself is quite crude and ill-advised. It is always better to Ascend through one's own comprehension, rather than through external means, such as by anchoring oneself to celestial bodies.]

She paused.

[However, this ancestor can sense a certain level of genius in the method Diablo used. It is a purely utilitarian method of ascension, one that sacrifices the individual's future for the good of a collective. There are dense Cosmic markings dotted throughout each world's interior, as well as inside the star. I fully believe that you would know if the Kolvaxians were attempting to breach a world's core.]

Melody's expression turned a bit glum. [Too bad we won't have this benefit once we move on to Pixiv. They don't have Cosmics guarding their planet cores.]

[It is somewhat unfortunate.] The Phoenix readily agreed. [But in my view, the fairies will not be so easily deceived. You know little of the fairies' true nature, but this venerable is well aware of certain Truths from the ancient times. The fairies fought a war so shocking, vicious, and brutal that it would make our current conflict seem like child's play. They lost their home galaxy to the Dark Ones, a fate we may someday face if misfortune continues to build within humanity's destiny. They may appear to you as dainty and beautiful princesses, but their eldest ones are battle-hardened warriors adept at tactical thinking on a strategic layer.]

The Phoenix continued. [All of this is to say that this noble one would be shocked beyond belief if the fairies did not erect powerful formations capable of detecting Kolvaxian intrusions on their homeworld, and likely even the other worlds in their system. This is one capability in which the fairies far exceed other Sentients.]

After outlining her thought process, the Phoenix synchronized her work with Melody's efforts. The two of them began to resonate, and Melody was surprised to see that the Phoenix was able to draw upon Melody's innate Cosmic power.

[How is this possible?] Melody asked.

[This Cosmic is one who has long mastered the peaceful power of fire and flames. Your energy comes directly from a stellar flame. Thus, this flametouched entity can effectively channel your energy. If you were to resist me, my efforts would end in smoke, but so long as you are willing, I can temporarily harness your power as if it were mine.]

Melody nodded. The Phoenix's explanation made perfect sense, given that Melody's Cosmic status came as a result of her connection to multiple white-hot planet cores, and a star at the center of the system.

Minutes passed. The Phoenix conjured a massive amount of power as her Divine Sense swept across Sharmur System.

For a brief moment, Melody's body began to heat up. She felt as if she were about to burst into flames!

Inside the Cube, the Phoenix inflated in size as she transferred power from Sharmur's star into Melody, then through Melody into the Phoenix herself. Her aura rose and her

eyes burst with divine rays of light.

Not long after...

The Sharmur system teleported into the Cube!

In a single instant, every planet in the system disappeared, seemingly vanishing from existence, along with all the life forms on those worlds.

Not just them, but Melody as well.

In Melody's eyes, the stars in the galaxy abruptly disappeared, replaced instead with infinitely distant golden walls tens of lightyears away, walls which spanned the entirety of the Void in all directions. Melody's eyes went wide as she realized she was no longer in Realspace, but had now appeared inside the Cube.

She was still alive. She hadn't died!

The transference was a success!

Melody's mood soared. She gritted her teeth and cheered, her voice silently shouting into the vacuum of the Cube's internal void.

She was alive, she could sense the Sharmur worlds, and now she could also sense the other pocket worlds, as well as the distant Phoenix!

The Phoenix rapidly accelerated, flapping her wings to fly toward Melody. Within just a few minutes, she drew close enough for Melody to spot her with her eyes, even though Melody's Cosmic Sense had detected the Phoenix well before she moved.

The Phoenix's body rapidly deflated in size. Before, she had risen to a height greater than any skyscraper on ancient Earth, but now she was 'only' a few hundred feet tall. This was her resting height when her body was not affected by the mana flowing within her. Compared to the 6.5 foot Melody, the Phoenix seemed grand and impressive, while her junior Demon Deity looked like a tiny ant at her feet.

[Phoenix... you did it. Great job!] Melody praised.

[This noble one could not have accomplished such a feat without your assistance. Do not sell yourself short, child.] The Phoenix gently chided. [With this, humanity's future is assured, at least in the short term. But if we want them to truly thrive, we must immediately make haste. I have already begun accelerating the Cube toward Pixiv. We should arrive there within one and a half of Sharmur's rotations.]

[I hope Raphael won't be able to react in time to our movements.] Melody said, a hint of worry in her voice.

[As do I.] The Phoenix added.

What neither one of them knew was that, at that very moment, something had just occurred which would drag Raphael's attention far away from humanity and the Cube...

* * *

On the world of Sharmur.

The humans waited, their hearts palpitating with fear. They didn't know what would happen to them, but they feared the teleportation of an entire star system would cause mass mayhem and death if things went poorly.

What if the transfer process killed Melody and her death caused the planets to implode? Nobody knew exactly what would happen, and thus their imaginations ran wild.

But then, seemingly out of nowhere, the sky changed form.

The stars vanished, and a brilliant golden color shone down on Sharmur, only a bit less bright than Sharmur's star itself! The abrupt change caught everyone off guard. Many people nearly jumped out of their skin with fright, but eventually news was passed down the grapevine from humanity's leaders.

The transfer was complete. Sharmur was now located within the Cube!

A celebration followed. People started laughing and cheering, hugging their friends and family, clapping one another on the back, and making self-aware jokes regarding their demise which never came.

It was as if the collective consciousness of humanity had sighed in relief!

At this point, 60% of the humans in the Milky Way lived on Sharmur, while 39% lived on Pixiv and the remaining 1% were scattered around at various locations.

The human leaders had considered either transporting all the humans to Sharmur or to Pixiv temporarily, but they ultimately settled on transferring a small portion on people to Pixiv in an attempt to balance out the populations for a while. There were a lot of considerations behind this decision.

First, what if the transference killed Melody? If all the humans were on Sharmur and Melody's death ended up bringing ruin to the system, then humanity would go extinct in

one fell swoop! This was obviously a terrible outcome. Putting everyone on Pixiv would prevent disaster from happening.

But secondly, what if nothing happened and Melody was fine after the transference? Now all those humans would be stuck on Pixiv, potentially unable to enter the Cube until it arrived 1.5 days later. According to Hans Wagner, humanity's current number one technological innovator after the death of Phoebe Hiro, the Warpgate on Sharmur would no longer work properly once the planet was inside the Cube. These gates were not designed to work inside pocket dimensions.

Perhaps in time humanity might be able to overcome these technical limitations, but if Hans was correct, then all the Phoenix would have accomplished was shoving empty worlds inside the Cube. That would defeat the entire point!

And finally, all the humans would then be stuck on Pixiv, waiting for the Cube to arrive. What if the Kolvaxians chose that exact moment to make a move? Then humanity would be completely lost again! It would be another disastrous outcome.

Therefore, the final decision was to split humanity between both worlds. If the transference went well, more than half of humanity's future would be safe even if the Kolvaxians immediately attacked Pixiv. If the transference went poorly, a little less than half of humanity would ultimately survive... but their future would be grim at best.

In the end, everything went well. General Chadwick and Linda Adams both heaved huge sighs of relief. Linda was on Sharmur, but Chadwick was back on Pixiv. He learned the outcome only a little after she did, but it did not dampen his enthusiasm.

"We've succeeded." Linda said to the senior officers inside Melodia's Military Command, located in the eastern part of the city. "The Cube is now enroute to Pixiv. Everyone, please pass on my orders to stand down from Yellow Alert. The city may return to normal operations."

The room erupted into cheers. Linda smiled as one person after another cheered humanity's survival. Some even wept. For too long, it had felt as if a Sword of Damocles had hung above humanity's head, threatening to fall from the heavens and bisect their species' future in half. But now, that threat had mostly evaporated.

Linda didn't join in on the celebrations. She was relieved, of course, but it had been a long time since her smile was genuine.

The death of Neil had dealt a permanent blow to her heart. She always felt as if a part of her was missing. All the joys of the world had become muted. The color of gray pervaded her sight.

Though this depression had infected her soul, it was slightly countered by a hope deep within her heart. Since the Kolvaxians were not a mindless hive, but were actually a creation of Archangel Uzziel, was it possible that someday humanity could counter the creatures and return them to their original forms?

Could Neil... still be saved?

Linda shuddered. She wanted this to be the case more than anything else in the world. She wanted to accidentally stumble upon Neil the Kolvaxian, subdue him, then transform him back into his original self.

But how likely was this to happen?

She felt the chances were astronomically low. It seemed impossible to ever save Neil.

Only the tiny spark of hope for his rescue someday kept her going. That, and her lightly swollen belly. She had to keep on persevering for the sake of their child, at the least.

"Linda." Someone said, shaking her out of her thoughts. Linda turned to see Debra standing beside her. Debra pushed her glasses up her nose.

"Sorry. What did you say?" Linda asked.

Debra cleared her throat. "Now that we know transference of Demon Deity systems is possible, we need to decide whether or not to invite other Deities into the Cube."

Linda didn't say anything for a while. She lowered her eyes and looked at the ground.

"Once we take Pixiv, assuming it's still safe to do so by the time we get there... I'm not sure if I want to invite other Demon Deities into the Cube. I simply cannot bring myself to trust them."

"We could transfer one or two inside." Debra suggested. "One additional Deity, even a Middle Cosmic, would be suppressed by Melody and the Phoenix. Two would be pushing our luck, though. Another option is to target Low and Bottom Cosmic Deities. They are of little threat and would be too weak to put up a fight against Melody, while still offering us strategic defensive value. Every additional Cosmic is another layer of protection."

Linda continued to hesitate. "I just don't know, Debra. At this point, I'd rather take in additional worlds without any demons, even barren rocks, just so humanity has plenty of raw resources to meet our future needs. Humanity has to start building up its own military strength, not relying on the goodwill of our former enemies."

Debra scrunched up her lips. She looked away, staring off into the distance thoughtfully.

"Hm. You might be right. I only worry that-"

Right as she was about to speak, a figure suddenly appeared in the room, causing her to pause mid-sentence.

"Melody." Debra said. "I'm glad to see you weren't hurt."

"Me too!" Melody chirped. "Sorry for popping in. I overheard your conversation. Uh... I guess I should have mentioned this sooner. We're... not going to be taking in any other demon worlds."

Debra and Linda both looked at Melody in surprise.

"We aren't?" Linda asked. "Why not?"

Even though Linda already didn't think it was a good idea, she was still stunned by the finality contained within Melody's tone. It brokered no argument.

"After the transference, I decided to have a chat with Demon Deity Auger." Melody said. She sighed. "Auger told me the demons have come up with a new plan. They aren't interested in joining us inside the Cube anymore."

"What new plan is Auger speaking of?" Debra pressed.

"They're calling it... the Divine Demon Empire." Melody said. "Using Barbatos's power, the Demon Deities are going to haul multiple star systems close to one another, forming a web of tightly packed Super Systems. Over time, they will conglomerate all the Demon Deities into a single star system spanning around ten lightyears in every direction, with hundreds or even thousands of planets. Since the Demon Deities are planet locked, they won't be able to extend their power outward, but by concentrating everyone's strength, they might be able to slowly drag this new Super System across the void! It's a long-term plan, but one that they'll be working on starting immediately."

Linda gasped. "That's... a surprising idea, but not a bad one at all! Demon Deities will be able to form a web of protection, reinforcing one another in the event the Kolvaxians

attack."

Debra also looked impressed, but then her expression shifted. "It's a decision born of desperation. While these demonic worlds might end up heavily protected, the demons will be concentrating all their military power into a tiny pocket of the galaxy. They cannot grow any stronger. They will stagnate while the Kolvaxians continue to take over one world after another."

"Furthermore," Debra added, "If something were to happen and the Kolvaxians did infest one of the demon's worlds, the entire Super System would risk falling. Outside of Diablo, nobody else has any ability to actually fight the demons off their worlds."

"No. You're wrong." Linda said. "The Dolgrimites possess this ability. If the demons are going to suffer a loss, they can request backup from the Dolgrimites to drive the Kolvaxians away. The Dolgrimites are like the natural predators of the Kolvaxians. Thus, the risk of a full collapse from one infected world does not seem as high as you think."

Melody massaged her forehead. "Yeah, uh, sorry but all this strategy-stuff's got me tired. Look, we're inside the Cube now, okay? We're good for now. I'm gonna work with the Phoenix to spread out the human population a bit more. We're also going to do something with the time dilation inside the Cube."

Linda looked interested. "What do you mean?"

"I uh... I... don't really know." Melody said, somewhat lamely. "Hey, Phoenix. Phoenix! Can you explain it to these people?"

Melody looked up at the sky as she spoke, also transmitting her voice telepathically outward to draw the Phoenix's attention.

Not long afterward, a spark of light flew down from the sky. It passed right through the solid walls of humanity's military HQ, then appeared before Linda and the others.

[Greetings, Linda of Adams and Debra of Grey. I am the Phoenix.] She said. [This revered one offers her apologies for not coming to you sooner. I have been quite busy settling some matters regarding your star system.]

"No need to apologize, really." Linda said, cupping her hands and bowing her head respectfully. "I'm thankful for all your help, Phoenix. You are humanity's savior."

The Phoenix's tiny sparkle of light was unable to alter its form, but an imprint of the Phoenix's appearance spread into the minds of both humans, surprising them with its

authenticity. This illusion burned brightly in their mind's eyes, making them feel as if they were looking at an avatar of the Phoenix directly!

[Let this ancient one explain my plans.] The Phoenix continued. [Humanity needs to develop. Your population is small. You lack manpower. You have an extremely large amount of living space available to you now, but little time to populate it. Thus, I shall use my abilities to increase the speed of the Cube's internal time dilation.]

[First, I must add Pixiv into the Cube's interior. Only once I have done that will I increase the time dilation. This is because moving star systems inside the Cube will become tens or even hundreds of times more mana-intensive once the time dilation has increased. It would be best to devour all the systems we need first, since speeding up and slowing down the time dilation inside an artifact as massive as the Cube will cost me a lot of energy I am currently lacking.]

[Secondly, this ancestor will need to consult with the fairies, because the formations wrapped around humanity's miniature bubble worlds are outside my realm of expertise. We must disentangle them first before I can synchronize all the dilation speeds in the Cube. If I do not do this first... the worlds may explode, killing everyone inside.]

Linda blanched. "Y-yes... let's please avoid killing people with needless rushing, great Phoenix."

[Thirdly,] the Phoenix continued, [once the fairies have joined us, this flametouched one shall begin working with the fairies to establish specialized zones for certain subsets of humanity. I have long been aware of the Wordsmith's plans for the humans, though he perished before he could bring them to fruition.]

"Hm?" Melody grunted. "What plans are you talking about?"

[They are not a secret.] The Phoenix patiently explained. As a powerful ancient Cosmic, she was more than capable of handling a conversation with multiple people using her avatar while attending to other matters far from the planet's voidspace. [You know the Wordsmith cured humanity's Flaw, correct?]

Melody slowly nodded. "Well, yeah. But nothing's really come of it."

[That is because not enough time has passed.] The Phoenix said. [The first aspect of fixing the flaw is a huge boost in human reproduction rates. Do not roll your eyes at this matter. Humanity lacks manpower. Being able to rapidly impregnate not only other

humans, but non-humans as well... this shall grant humanity a population growth speed unmatched in the Milky Way's history. With a higher time dilation, entire generations will reach adulthood every year.]

[With more humans, we will begin to see more Heroes rising. Not Lowborn Heroes, but Trueborn ones. Powerful warriors with unique abilities capable of beating back our enemies.]

The Phoenix swept her gaze around the room.

[What this noble one has just explained can be said to be the smallest tip of an iceberg greater than your imagination. What of the 'Power Gloves' Jason Hiro made? What of Jepthath's Legion? What of the advancements being made inside the Hall of Heroes and Chrona?]

The Phoenix's avatar relaxed her speech. [What humans lack is not military power, but time to grow their existing capabilities into maturity. This ancient one fully intends to uplift an army capable of inflicting a grievous blow upon the Archangels. Their plot to consume the galaxy is a vile one indeed.]

"Say... about that..." Melody said slowly. "Weren't you made by Camael? Shouldn't you be on the angels' side?"

The Phoenix's avatar momentarily brightened. A slight sensation of anger transmitted into the minds of everyone present.

[Do not take this ancient one to be a slave of the Archangels! I was made for a purpose, and that purpose is *gone*. The Dark Dragon has escaped my clutches. Dolgris is the enemy of all life within the galaxy, but my former masters have fallen equally far into the depths of depravity. Right now, uplifting the humans will serve to reinvigorate my original purpose, as well as to counteract the evils committed by Uzziel, the Plaguebringer.]

[My master, Camael, is long dead.] The Phoenix concluded, her voice softening. [But even if she returned from beyond the grave, she once told me that I was not her slave. I am free to live my life how I choose.]

Linda was moved. "And you want your life to have a purpose."

[That is right, young one.] The Phoenix concluded. [Who among us does not seek a purpose? The incurious, the foolish, the blind, and the stubborn, perhaps. But those with any sort of intellect or aspirations always have a purpose they seek. Mine is the

eradication of the Dark Dragon. But even if I fail, there is still righteousness in assisting the rise of interesting young seeds, such as yourselves.]

The Phoenix seemed to smile in a way only a flaming bird-deity could.

[You humans are so cute. You have your little squabbles and sometimes fight among one another, but where there is hatred, there is love. Humans can unite against external threats quickly and efficiently. This ancient one finds them much more pleasing to her eyes than the hypocritical, self-righteous angels, who constantly made new life only to try and enslave it afterward.]

Melody snorted. "Took the words right out of my mouth."

The four spoke for a while longer. Eventually, the Phoenix departed, leaving the other women to their devices.

"Now that we're about to enter into an era of stability, it's time we settled some matters." Debra said. "The Hell of Lust has been with us for a while, but I think we should finally integrate them properly into human society."

Melody nodded. "I don't have a lot to do now that the transference is complete. Leave it to me."

Humanity's Great Era was finally about to descend...

Part 738: Master and Pupil

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. The world of Sharmur.

Cassiel, Belial, Beelzebub, and Kiari all stood together on a western mountaintop in Melodia, waiting to see what would happen next. Before their eyes, the stars in the sky abruptly vanished, followed by the appearance of a brilliant golden light that shrouded the entire sky. This light came from the interior of the Cube, and was just as bright as Sharmur's star, except it came from all directions. The abrupt change in luminosity made all these powerful champions of humanity squint their eyes. They had to look away, since the brightness was so extreme.

"Looks like it's finally done." Belial said. "I hope Melody is okay."

"Yeah." Kiari said, her expression downcast.

Ever since her husband's funeral, she had been shrouded in a fog of gloom. Sometimes the fog would lift, but it would always return. Belial had been going out of her way to spend a bit of time with Kiari, given their shared trauma. But right now, Belial had to stay beside Cassiel due to the threat of Gressil returning at any moment. Thus, she could only talk with Kiari if Kiari happened to drop by.

Cassiel's mood was equally somber. It hadn't even been a day since Gressil terrorized her, but she had already recovered somewhat. She still jumped at shadows. She still flinched if she thought she saw something out of the corner of her eyes. She believed he was watching her at all times, which made sleep impossible to come by.

But, despite these issues, Cassiel had slowly been building up her courage again. She was afraid of Gressil, yes. Terrified, even. But at the same time, she was also *tired* of being afraid of him. It was exhausting, jumping at every little shadow that strayed across her vision. Her nerves were well beyond the point of being 'frazzled' and now they just wanted a rest.

There were dark bags under Cassiel's eyes. She blinked her eyes slowly, then leaned her head against Belial's shoulder, wrapping an arm around the succubi's arm afterward.

Belial glanced at the sleepy angel. "You want to rest?"

"Yes..." Cassiel said. "But... I don't know... if I can."

Belial chewed her lower lip. She looked at Beelzebub and Kiari. They met her gaze, sympathy in their eyes.

"Let's go to that underbrush over there." Kiari suggested. "Cass, you can take a nap, alright? The three of us will watch over you."

Cassiel's eyes drooped a little further. "I... alright. Thank you. I really do... need it."

Belial helped Cassiel over to the underbrush where the brilliant light of the Cube wasn't so oppressive. Beneath the dense canopy of the forest atop the mountain, Cassiel laid down among some plants, and Belial sat beside her cross-legged. Cassiel hesitantly laid her head on Belial's thigh, then closed her eyes.

Pureblooded angels didn't need to sleep. Lazarites also didn't usually need to sleep unless they were running low on Faith Energy. But Cassiel's exhaustion came less from her biology and more from her burnt-out mental capacitors. She just didn't have much left in her tank.

The other two Emperors sat nearby. Beelzebub and Kiari sat somewhat apart, forming a triangle with Belial, Cassiel positioned in the middle of them. In this way, they could watch out for each other's backs, just in case Gressil sneak-attacked them. Kiari also maintained a close connection to thousands of venomous bugs in the forest. She secretly hoped Gressil would show his face so she could force a swarm of critters down his gullet. Making him choke to death would be a humorously appropriate way to eliminate his evil from the universe.

There was something *mildly* humorous about the last living angel being watched over by three Demon Emperors. But that went without saying.

After the trio sat down, they remained silent for a while. Cassiel was truly exhausted. She fell asleep within ten minutes, her breathing steadying as she entered a dream realm of unknown sorts.

Belial looked at Beelzebub and Kiari. They nodded, agreeing not to even mention Gressil, lest they accidentally cause Cassiel to subconsciously endure nightmares, or just worsen the ones she was probably already having.

"The Phoenix tells me everything went well." Beelzebub said, his voice quiet so as to not wake Cassiel. "Sharmur's star system is now inside the Cube. We no longer have Warpgate access to the Labyrinth, or anywhere else."

Kiari looked at Cassiel, Inwardly, she wondered if Gressil traveled back to the Labyrinth, or if he came to Sharmur before it was transported. Naturally, she did not give voice to this question.

"In a day and a half, we'll reach Pixiv." Kiari said instead. "Assuming all goes well... what next? Does the Cube just hide while humans live in time acceleration?"

"It cannot hide forever." Beelzebub warned. "The Cube can conceal its presence to a great extent thanks to the dimensional barriers between its realm and Realspace. However, Cosmics who approach the Cube's general vicinity can still sense its presence. They won't be able to pinpoint it easily, but if they possess spatial magic or psionics or other similar abilities, they might be able to forcefully enter the Cube's dimension."

Beelzebub was quite knowledgeable about the Cube now. He wasn't an idiot, and was in fact quite the learned demon. He could communicate telepathically with the Phoenix from any distance in the universe, made easier now that he was inside the Cube itself. In this way, the Phoenix didn't even need to visit these Emperors. She could let Beelzebub do all the talking.

"Raphael possesses such abilities." Kiari muttered. She hadn't interacted with the Archangel ever, but like most people, she knew the general intel on him. Now that he was one of humanity's greatest enemies, this intel had been widely disseminated among those might otherwise not have known.

"Any luck getting in touch with Chrona?" Belial asked.

Beelzebub shook his head. "None. We have no idea what their situation is. The last we heard, their time dilation was still accelerating... so..."

He trailed off, the implication clear.

The only hope humanity had of contacting Chrona was via the fairies, or possibly Marie Becker, since Rebecca the Cybernite was inside Chrona.

In the worst case situation, it was possible Chrona's dimension could accelerate to such a speed that it would implode, killing everyone inside!

Based on the predictions of humanity's few remaining experts, particularly their fairy allies, Hans Wagner, and Mandy Hiro inside the Hall of Heroes, it didn't seem as though Chrona would be destroyed just yet, but time was running out.

"There's a bigger question we need to ask." Beelzebub said, carefully looking between Kiari and Belial as he spoke. "Can we win? Can *humanity* win? Mere survival is not good enough. If the humans' only goal is to survive, they are not thinking ahead far enough."

He continued. "The Phoenix has spoken to me regarding a few Truths. Did you know that at some point in the near future, maybe a year from now, maybe a million years from now, the barriers around all the galaxies in the universe are going to drop? Once they drop, an extragalactic war will begin!"

Belial nodded. "I've heard about that. Didn't catch all the details, though."

"Well, let me tell you then." Beelzebub explained. "It's known as Akasha's War. Sometimes referred to as The Game of Rulers. Often deemed *The Game* for short. Once it begins, the war will not end until this Eternity ends. And when the Eternity ends, the entire universe will collapse, then a new Eternity will begin! We're talking about trillions, even septillions of years between the birth and death of our universe!"

He spoke fervently, though he kept his voice low so as to not wake up Cassiel.

After a long moment, Belial shrugged. "So?"

"So? What do you mean *so*, woman?" Beelzebub spat. "Humanity's very existence hangs in the balance. If you think things are bad now, just wait until the Akashic Barriers drop. Humans, demons, and everyone else will become meat on the chopping block. Our galaxy is way too weak to handle enemies from other galaxies!"

Beelzebub frowned. Despite his words, neither Belial nor Kiari looked particularly bothered about it.

"I know it seems like a big deal to you, Beelzebub." Kiari eventually said. "But... I'm only 3,000 years old. Even Samantha is only 100,000 years old. If this big war starts in a million years, then she'll be 10 times older, stronger, and wiser. I'll be hundreds of times older, stronger, and wiser. Assuming we're even alive at that point."

"So, the way I see it," Kiari continued, "I think you're focusing on events that might be so far in the future, humanity will have already become way stronger, or been rendered extinct. We have to focus on the here and now."

Belial snorted. "That's not all, Kiari. The fact is, humanity is going to go extinct anyway. All of us are. Once the Eternity ends, we'll all be dead. So, winning or losing a far-future war might matter for our descendants, but worrying about surviving until the end

of the Eternity... it really doesn't matter. All I care about, personally, is protecting the people I care about."

Belial subconsciously stroked Cassiel's hair as she said this. She didn't even realize what she'd done.

"Well..." Beelzebub relented. "You're not *wrong*. Wringing my hands over future events tens of times more distant than the birth of my universe does feel rather idiotic."

Beelzebub thought about it more, and he realized that while the Phoenix was incredibly ancient and had been born quite close to the birth of the universe, very few other entities in the Milky Way were like her. Beelzebub himself certainly wasn't. For the Phoenix, 100 million years might feel like a thousand years for Belial, or a hundred years for Kiari. Their scales of thinking were far too different.

At the same time, what was the point worrying about humanity's survival when they, and every other species in the universe, would die off someday anyway? Nobody could truly live forever, not even the Rulers who endured multiple Eternities. Perhaps even Akasha himself might die someday.

Beelzebub chuckled quietly. He returned his attention to the other two.

"How about this then?" Beelzebub suggested. "Let's just focus on making humanity stronger for the sake of making them less vulnerable. We want to avoid future tragedies as much as possible."

Kiari nodded. "I'd like that."

"So would I." Belial added. "But none of us are inventors. We're not builders, or technologists, or anything like that. We just... fight. What good are we?"

"You say we're not builders?" Beelzebub retorted. "Kiari's giant bugs can rapidly build cities. Your great strength and ability to stretch your body would surely help in assembling giant machines and structures. As for me? At the very least I could make for a capable... welder!"

Hardly had the words left his mouth before Beelzebub's face fell.

Welder? Oh devils... is that all I'm good for? Melting two pieces of metal together?!

"Actually, Beelzebub," Belial interjected, "you're an *energy* producer. You can produce vast amounts of fire with minimal mana cost, and you recently started learning how to

create electricity and lightning. I bet your powers have even more practical uses for humanity than mine would. Phoebe told me that once, some time back."

Beelzebub was surprised. He hadn't really given the full extent of his abilities much thought.

A few minutes of silence followed. A new idea bubbled inside Beelzebub's mind.

"I need to... think for a bit." Beelzebub said, gesturing toward a cliff high above them. "I'm going to go up there. You two, just call out if you need me."

"Oh. Okay." Belial said, raising an eyebrow. "But... if Gressil comes..."

Beelzebub stood up, then he snorted at Belial.

"If the former Second Emperor of Demonkind can't rip that ugly bastard a new hole, what will I be able to do? As long as you're here, he won't have the stones to show his face."

Beelzebub waved off her concerns. He strolled away, leaving the three women alone together.

Cassiel continued to snooze, her mind having drifted off into a deep dream. With Beelzebub gone, Belial and Kiari found themselves able to have more of a girl talk... having a man nearby changed the atmosphere enough that they never fully felt comfortable opening up.

And so, like this, they began to talk about a great many things. Their feelings, the changes coming to Sharmur and other worlds, and many similar such things.

But while they talked about the matters which were important to them, Beelzebub clambered onto a stone outcropping high above the women, where he could leap off and reach them in seconds if something went wrong. He was far enough away that even with his exceptional hearing he couldn't really hear their whispering, but if they screamed or yelled, he would be able to reinforce them within seconds.

As Beelzebub sat down cross-legged, he looked up into the brilliant glowing sky and sighed.

"Executor Sartran." Beelzebub said mildly. "How are you doing, you absolute bastard?"

Beelzebub reached into his soul and extracted a glowing lump of light. Unlike Jason Hiro and several others, Beelzebub did not have a Mind Realm. Thus, several weeks earlier, when he killed Executor Sartran following the destruction of Tarus II, he devoured Sartran's soul and put it into hibernation, rather than allowing the Executor to roam around freely within a living soul world.

Sartran's soul awakened. It shuddered in Beelzebub's grasp.

[I... where am I? Beelzebub! No! You killed me?!]

"I did." Beelzebub said mildly. "It's the least you deserve... after what you did to Tarus II. Because of the Volgrim, the Wordsmiths are dead, along with a million humans. Do you feel even the slightest regret over your evil deeds?"

Sartran's soul dimmed slightly. He could not take physical form, but his emotions were plainly visible to the one holding him in their grasp.

[...Beelzebub. I was not the one who destroyed your world. It was the Second Founder who did. And she was likely deceived-]

"By Creator Demila. Yes. I am well aware." Beelzebub said. "Quite some time has passed since we last spoke. About three weeks. Demila is dead. So are around 95% of all Psions."

A long moment of silence hung in the air.

[Wha... what?] Sartran asked, his tone ashen. [No... you... you are lying.]

"I wish I were." Beelzebub said. "Not that you Volgrim don't *deserve* to suffer a reverse-genocide after what you did to Tarus II. It's quite amusing to see how quickly karma slapped you across the face! But unfortunately the war situation has changed as a result, and now everything is all messed up. Thus, my light regret about your people."

Sartran was confused. He had been essentially trapped in stasis inside Beelzebub's soul, not knowing what happened in the world outside. Thus, Beelzebub took a few minutes to catch the former Executor up to speed.

Beelzebub told Sartran about the destruction of Tarus II, Demila's betrayal, her assault on the Psion homeworlds, and her ultimate death on Volgarius, though Beelzebub didn't know the exact manner in which she died. Thanks to the Phoenix's keen senses, Beelzebub only knew that her soul had been extinguished, perhaps through some secret

counter-measure by the Founders. But the Phoenix also knew of Mephisto's appearance, as well as Executor Nufaris's final sacrifice to kill him.

[Nufaris...] Sartran said, his soul dimming even further. [All the Executors... dead. Our Empire in ruins...]

Beelzebub sneered. "Oh, you poor thing. I could never imagine what you're going through. Don't worry, though. Things can only get worse from here! It turns out the Kolvaxians are actually agents of Archangel Uzziel, working in tandem with Archangel Raphael! Who knew, eh? Hahahaha, and now the Plague has us all surrounded, and our deaths are going to come sooner or later!"

[Why did you bring me out?] Sartran asked. [Merely to gloat? To laugh at my misfortune?]

"WELL, I'd be LYING if I said watching you cry about all this wasn't terribly entertaining!" Beelzebub roared with laughter. "It's really quite funny watching the galaxy's biggest bullies get their comeuppance! A bit of a knee-slapper if I don't say so myself!"

[Beelzebub...] Sartran groaned. [Look. Listen to me. I am *truly* sorry about Tarus II. We were all deceived by Demila. She gave us false intelligence and brought ruin not only to humanity, but the Volgrim as well. True, humanity endured the first blow, but make no mistake, her actions were an attack secretly aimed at the Volgrim. Both our species were victims of her machinations.]

Beelzebub's laughter died off. He rubbed his nose with his free hand. "Of course I know that, you dimwit. Do you think I'm stupid? I already know we're both victims. But it's still quite funny seeing the 'omnipotent' Volgrim Empire get slapped around by one rogue agent like Demila! So much for the GENIUS of your First Founder! I guess even his 'keen strategic mind' couldn't see through her deception."

Sartran was quiet for a time.

[That was because Unarin had a blind spot for her. Demila was a million orbits of age. She had loyally served the Empire since her emergence. Even I was deceived. I refuse to believe she was always like this. Perhaps something changed her. Perhaps...]

Sartran mused to himself for a moment.

[Now that I think about it. Her personality did start to change not long ago. It was after... yes... I spoke to Nufaris about that matter. We dispatched her to execute Demon Emperor Gressil, but she somehow failed. It was a huge embarrassment. Gressil is well-known for being a liar and a deceiver. Is it possible he somehow grasped hold of her weakness and manipulated her to turn against her Empire?]

Beelzebub rolled his eyes. "Who cares? I'm sure there's some excuse you can use, some other person you can put the blame on. But it doesn't matter! What happened, *happened*, and now we need to move on."

Finally, Beelzebub decided to get around to the real reason he had retrieved Sartran's soul.

"I've come to consult with you." Beelzebub said. "I *was* thinking about just devouring your soul, but the Phoenix told me it wouldn't make me any stronger, and the soul contamination of a Low Cosmic would surely weaken me by a great deal."

Sartran's outward projection of emotions didn't change. He seemed unaffected by Beelzebub's threats.

[What makes you think I would be willing to help the one who killed me?] Sartran asked. [Our enmity now is beyond redemption.]

"Oh, pish-posh, don't be such a sourpuss." Beelzebub said, waving his other hand lightly. "Your Empire is in pieces. The demons are scrambling to pull themselves together to stand a chance against the Plague, the humans are going into hiding, and the rest of the galaxy is *screwed* if current trends keep up."

He continued. "Sartran, you once gave me some useful tips regarding my powers. I was wondering if you wouldn't like to educate me further?"

The Executor scoffed. [Why? So you can someday unleash your flames upon the Volgrim? Why would I empower a potential enemy to my Empire?]

"If your glorious Empire hadn't gotten its pants slapped off by Demila, you'd be right. But at this point, I like to think we're... even." Beelzebub said slowly. "That is, so long as your idiotic Founders don't fall for another spy in their midst and send another attack at the humans again. If that were to happen, then your worries would be rooted in reality."

A long moment of silence fell. Sartran's soul rested in Beelzebub's grasp. He looked at Beelzebub, and Beelzebub looked back at him.

[So... you wish for me to... teach you?] Sartran asked.

"Yes. I want to master my powers properly." Beelzebub said.

[Don't you find your request a bit shameless? I'm trapped within your grasp. I'm a hostage.] Sartran retorted.

"A hostage? Hardly." Beelzebub snorted. "That would imply I was using you to extort for a ransom. Your Empire has no idea you're still alive. I'm simply tapping into my resources to empower myself."

Beelzebub paused.

"Well, I suppose if you're unwilling, I could ask the Phoenix to help me extract the knowledge from your soul forcibly. It would no doubt be excruciating, and you would die. I just think it'd bring me bad karma to kill you in such a manner. I'd rather learn from you properly."

Sartran shuddered. He was no expert on soul manipulation, but he knew plenty of Psions who were. Extracting knowledge from a soul would take a long time, and it would mean excruciating unending agony until the soul itself ultimately collapsed from the pain.

[I... I understand.] Sartran said reluctantly. [You want a teacher, and I happen to possess the type of knowledge you need. Will you swear to me you won't bring your power to bear against the Volgrim Empire?]

Beelzebub rolled his eyes. "Only if the Volgrim Empire doesn't do something *stupid* again like they did with Tarus II. If they do... I will not hold back."

Sartran considered Beelzebub's words.

[If I am being fully honest with myself... it is true that my Empire harmed the humans. Undeservedly? I am not certain. But as they say, an eye for an eye makes the world blind. I greatly hope another deceiver like Demila does not cause my people, or yours, any further harm.]

Sartran's soul seemed to sag a little.

[Very well. I will teach you my ways, Beelzebub. Properly, this time, as a master and pupil. I have to admit, I was interested in you from the moment we met. Your powers are similar to mine, yet we use them in different ways. Perhaps we could both learn from each other.]

Beelzebub nodded. "I'd like that. I do apologize for killing you in a flash of rage. Admittedly, I didn't know all the facts at the same, and I might have overreacted a *teensy* bit."

Sartran looked down at his disembodied soul.

[...I suppose that is one way to describe past matters.]

Like this, the atmosphere lightened between them somewhat.

"If possible, I will see if I can get you a new body at some point." Beelzebub said. "In fact, I'll even swear on it. So long as you teach me properly, I'll get you a new body. So long as the Volgrim Empire doesn't attack humanity again, I won't attack them. I swear on my honor as a Demon Overlord!"

[Very well. Your vow is about the most I could hope for- wait, what did you say?] Sartran suddenly asked. [What is a 'Demon Overlord'? Aren't you a Demon Deity?]

Beelzebub gave Sartran a weird look, but then he realized what the Executor meant. Beelzebub slapped his own face.

"Ahh, I suppose I forgot to mention... actually, I was a Middle Cosmic for a short while, but then I gave all my energy to the Phoenix, so I'm a mortal again. It turns out there's a level of mortal power above Demon Emperor called Demon Overlord. So that's me now!"

[You're not a Middle Cosmic anymore?!] Sartran shrieked. [Why didn't you say so from the start?! Here I was, worried you would turn your Cosmic power on the Volgrim Empire, but you're only a mortal now! I don't mind teaching a mere mortal how to wield their power... you could have saved us both a lot of breath!]

Beelzebub thought for a moment about mentioning that he actually maybe *possibly* had a way to ascend back to Cosmic again... but he wisely opted to keep his mouth shut.

"Right. That- sorry, Sartran. I guess it just didn't cross my mind."

The Executor harrumphed, then metaphorically crossed his arms in annoyance.

[*Demons*.]

Part 739: Experimentation

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. The world of Sharmur.

Two hours passed.

Beelzebub sat quietly atop the mountain cliff. He listened as his newest teacher reluctantly lectured to him. At the same time, electricity crackled between both of Beelzebub's palms, jumping from his right hand to his left hand and back again.

[The fundamental state of fire is simply energy. This is why the bridge between fire and lightning can be crossed with great ease by genius Psions, and ones such as yourself.] Sartran explained, his soul speaking from within Beelzebub's mind. [But in truth, fire and lightning are only two possible options for energy manipulators. They are still considered low level, brute-force applications of energy manipulation. The true value in energy manipulation comes from manipulating the weak nuclear force, the strong nuclear force, and electromagnetism directly.]

"Electromagnetism?" Beelzebub repeated. "I'm not familiar with this term. Based on the name, it sounds like it has something to do with electricity and magnets?"

[That is indeed one way of putting it.] Sartran said hesitantly. [A rather simplistic description, but acceptable for now. Electromagnetism allows one to control many different fundamental forces of nature. It is what computer circuitry is based on, so it's also quite valuable knowledge for Technopaths to possess.]

Beelzebub paused his electrical energy pulses to scratch his chin thoughtfully.

"Ose was always good with computers. And she manipulated lightning. I assumed the two went together, but based on what you're saying, she didn't go nearly far enough with what her abilities could accomplish."

[Presumably, if she could manipulate lightning, then she could have manipulated fire and electromagnetism itself.] Sartran acknowledged. [But don't take what I'm saying as irrefutable fact. Just because one 'can' do something does not mean they are 'able' to do it. Technically, most humans can train their bodies to become professional weightlifters and lift hundreds of kilos worth of weights, but not many actually do this.]

Sartran continued. [We Psions are able to live forever without fear of natural death. The longest-lived among us often reach a wall in our growth that prevents us from ascending to greater heights, and thus they often try to branch out and master new applications to their existing powers. Creator Demila was one such case. Despite being one million cycles of age, she could not normally rise past the 7th Level, and thus she instead worked on improving her fundamentals.]

"Until she decided to eat a bunch of you." Beelzebub muttered.

[Yes. Until she did... that.] Sartran said, his voice softening. [She was not a brilliant Psion. She was greedy, short-sighted, and only possessed decent capabilities. The fact she was able to rise to the 7th Level was more due to her perseverance and luck than a testament to her intellect.]

Beelzebub pondered Sartran's words. "Based on what you've said, is it possible that I, and many other demons like me, have truly been limiting ourselves based on preconceived notions of what we think our powers enable us to do? Could I have been wielding the power of lightning back when I was a Lord if someone hadn't defined my abilities so strictly for me?"

[Perhaps. However, it is a fact that the stronger one's connection to metaphysical powers grows, the broader their breadth of abilities can also become. When you were a Demon Lord, you likely could only control the basic element of fire at your highest possible level, and your connection to others would have been far weaker. The same is true of low-level Psions. Only around once we ascend to Cosmic can our kind truly branch out evenly in multiple directions.]

Sartran waved his hand. [But never mind all that. I think I've said enough, now. You should try using your powers more creatively.]

"I agree. But... how can I be more creative?" Beelzebub pondered. "I've always just... used the powers my body told me I would automatically know how to use."

[Hmm. A good question.] Sartran said. [How about this? Start by standing up.]

"Uh... alright, then."

Beelzebub shrugged. He stood up, then stretched his legs. Sitting on a rock cross-legged for two hours wasn't particularly comfortable, and his joints felt a little stiff.

[Alright. Now, let's go over your abilities, one by one.] Sartran suggested.

Beelzebub nodded. He didn't say anything for a moment as he thought about all the powers he possessed.

"Well. First off, Flame Shaping is my fundamental ability."

Beelzebub held up his hand. He conjured an orb of fire, then started spinning it around rapidly to condense it and increase its heat and explosive power. If he were to let go, it would probably explode and blow his arm off! But he instead deliberately slowed it down, then turned it into a plume of fire that arced up over his head like a fountain of water.

He changed the flame's shape a few more times to demonstrate his proficiency. Sartran raised an eyebrow. It was clear at a glance that Beelzebub's Flame Shaping was already at the highest level. He could bend and manipulate the flames by relying on pure combat instinct without even having to think about their form.

"There's also Fireportation." Beelzebub said.

He flicked a bit of fire over toward some shrubs on the edge of the mountain. When the vegetation burst into flame, Beelzebub suddenly exploded into smoke, then reappeared at the new location a split-second later.

Sartran gasped. [You've mastered a form of teleportation? Incredible! What are the limitations on range?]

Beelzebub frowned. "I... don't know. I don't use this ability often."

[What a waste! You absolutely must try to find the limits of how far you can travel!] Sartran urged. [How can you be so blind to the possibilities?]

"What possibilities?" Beelzebub asked. He looked genuinely clueless. "It's certainly a useful ability, but outside of saving a little time getting to places I don't see the extreme value you're implying."

Sartran sighed. [You truly do lack imagination, Beelzebub. I see now that you focus your attention on mere brute force and fighting. This is only one possibility among many that a metaphysical master should consider.]

The Executor started to lecture again. [Abilities can be divided into many different types. Offense, defense, healing, scouting, movement, strategic-macro, strategic-micro, summoning, empowerment, weakening, and more!]

[Think for a moment of other demons that you know.] Sartran continued. [Do you know of any demons who are good at delivering messages across vast distances to other demons?]

"Of course." Beelzebub said. "Any Warper, for one."

[Right. And how about demons who can summon other creatures or entities or weapons to fight for them?] Sartran pressed further.

"Hmm. Lucifer and Gressil could make new forms of life..." Beelzebub said hesitantly. "Oh, Uriel summoned Light Constructs when she fought me as well. Jason Hiro summoned other beings to life as well."

[Yes! Precisely.] Sartran exclaimed. [Ose was lightning fast in her movements. Belial can heal countless sorts of injuries. All of these demons, angels, Heroes, and so on have powers with unique uses, but the limitation for you demons is that you often do not consider alternative uses for your abilities.]

Now was the moment where Sartran started to get to his bigger point.

[Beelzebub, imagine a few months from now, something terrible happens. Kolvaxians break into the Cube, or the demons invade, or some other scenario. With your Fireportation power, depending on the limits, you could instantly reinforce any warzone by teleporting to a nearby fire source!]

Beelzebub frowned. "But what's the point if I have to light a fire and teleport to it? I might as well just fly over there myself."

[No, no, no...] Sartran sighed. [You're still thinking like an individual. What if humanity purposefully left lots of small fires flickering across their settlements and cities and other important areas for you to teleport to? What if your ability allows you to teleport hundreds of kilometers to a distant source of fire? What if you can teleport across a star system to another world? What if you can teleport to distant worlds inside different star systems?]

"I... I see!" Beelzebub exclaimed, suddenly realizing Sartran's true meaning. "I've never tested the limits of my teleportation ability. It simply didn't occur to me this was a possibility!"

[Exactly.] Sartran said, feeling relieved. [But we've still not gone far enough. Beelzebub, you can blow up parts of your body, yes?]

Beelzebub nodded again. "Yes. It's quite painful, but I can do it..."

[Have you ever tried combining Fireportation with nuclear body parts?] Sartran asked.

Once again, Beelzebub wore a look of surprise. "You mean... waiting until my enemy is close to a source of fire, then ripping off my arm and teleporting it to them, only to detonate my arm next to them? I don't think I've done that specific thing before, no..."

[Teleportation is an ability few Psions wield.] Sartran said, chiding Beelzebub as he would any other student. [It becomes more common as Psions rise past the 6th level, but even then, while most Executors can execute some form of teleportation, instantaneous movement, or other escape/traversal ability, most 7th Level Psions cannot, and sparingly few 6th Level Psions can do so even in a limited capacity. This means you are already far above most Cosmic Psions! For you to fail to use this power at the highest level, what can this be other than a waste?]

Beelzebub's expression became solemn. Indeed, he realized only now that Sartran's words were pointed straight at the heart of the matter. Beelzebub was already quite a bit more inventive than other demons, but that inventiveness quite literally only began after he spoke to Sartran during their first meeting. Before that moment, he simply used his abilities thoughtlessly, relying purely on what his instincts told him were possible.

"Another ability I often use is my Flame Whip..." Beelzebub said slowly. "I've used it to cut through opponents with heavy armor and other defenses."

[Have you ever used it to ensnare opponents?] Sartran questioned. [Whips and chains often make for great tools to temporarily immobilize strong enemies. Even if you only slow them down for a time unit or two, that can be enough time to rain hellfire upon them while they cannot resist. In fact, Executor Huron possesses the ability to transmute materials into new forms. One of his favorite methods is creating giant metal chains to bind his enemies. It has made his Kolvaxor doppelganger quite a bastard to battle against...]

"I've not used my whips in that way either." Beelzebub said, now beginning to feel quite ill regarding the wasteful usage of his flame powers. "I can shoot fire beams from my eyes. The pinpoint damage is quite strong, but overall, the ability is weak against strong enemies."

[That sounds like an ability that would work well in a surprise situation.] Sartran opined.

"A surprise situation?" Beelzebub repeated.

[Imagine your opponent has been hampering your movements, outplaying you at every opportunity, and agilely dodging your attacks.] Sartran continued to explain. [You have them thinking you're weak and they will surely defeat you. You charge up a mighty fireball to draw their attention, but you only pretend you're about to throw it at them. Instead, right when their attention is fully on your attack, you shoot a fire-beam from your eyes at theirs! If it strikes their eyes, you might cause immense damage. Even if the beam hits their eyes and does no damage, you might blind them for a split second. If they move to the side to avoid it, you can anticipate the movement. At the very least, you can startle them into making a mistake, giving you time to hit them with that charged fireball!]

Sartran logically walked Beelzebub through the possibilities, opening up the Demon Overlord's mind to many different ideas he hadn't considered before.

Beelzebub began to pace back and forth.

"Everything you've said makes sense. Now that I think about it, there are other things that jump to my mind I hadn't considered before. For example, since I can now wield electrical energy, maybe I can incorporate that into my existing techniques..."

A lightbulb seemed to go off in Beelzebub's head.

"That's it!" Beelzebub suddenly exclaimed.

Beelzebub turned to look out to the east, where he could see the ocean far in the distance. Between Beelzebub and that ocean, the city of Melodia stood with all its people bustling about, readying themselves for humanity's next transitional phase.

Beelzebub inhaled deeply. He concentrated his mind, causing the electrical energy in his brain to rise dramatically. Sparks erupted in his eyes as he looked at the distant shortline...

Zzzt...

Zzzzzzzzt...

Energy rapidly built up inside Beelzebub's body. Sweat dripped from his head as he struggled to focus his mind.

KZZAAAT!

All the energy abruptly exploded beneath Beelzebub's feet, making him yelp in alarm as he was unceremoniously launched into the air, causing him to spin fourteen times as he flew off the cliff's edge uncontrollably.

"Aaah!!"

Beelzebub tried to reorient himself in midair, but he was so startled from the misfire that he flew into the valley below and crashed into the trees, their branches lacerating his skin and tearing his clothes as he flopped down to the ground below and smashed his face against the ground.

"Oh... ohhh..." Beelzebub groaned, feeling multiple teeth shattered from the impact.

Moments later, Kiari rushed over. "Beelzebub? Are you okay? Did someone attack you? What's going on?!"

Kiari jumped in alarm when she saw Beelzebub's disheveled appearance. Not five seconds later, Belial ran over along with Cassiel, who had been woken up by the electrical explosion. The angel looked tired, but also fully alert, having been startled awake.

"Um... ffffiiine... I'm fuuhhhh-ine..." Beelzebub groaned, as he lifted himself up. His body felt weak for some reason. His arms shook as he tried to push himself up to a sitting position.

Kiari quickly walked over and wrapped her arm around Beelzebub's. She helped him stagger to his feet, then she frowned.

"What's wrong, Beelzebub? Why aren't you healing yet?"

Beelzebub was still dazed. He touched his face and realized his wounds hadn't scabbed over and healed like they usually would.

"I... I dun knowww." Beelzebub mumbled. His vision wavered.

Inside Beelzebub's mind, Sartran spoke, but only Beelzebub could hear him.

[You've suffered a backlash. This is something you've not experienced before, because you demons almost always rely on your instinctual powers. But whatever you were attempting to do was beyond your current base of knowledge. It happens to younger Psions all the time, and will result in the temporary weakening or even outright disabling of your metaphysical abilities. Rest for a while, and they will return.]

Beelzebub blinked slowly. He didn't say anything, due to his sudden onset of fatigue. Kiari helped him sit down with his back against a tree.

"Hey... Sam'mtha..." Beelzebub groaned. "Can Iiii troubbble you foraquickheal?"

Belial nodded. She looked at Cassiel, then stepped over to Beelzebub's side. After sending waves of healing magic into him, she finally brought Beelzebub back to a mostly intact state, though his body was still extremely lethargic.

"Did someone attack you?" Kiari asked again.

"No, no, nothing like that." Beelzebub said, rubbing the bottom of his jaw. Having to suffer with shattered teeth for three long minutes was an agonizing experience, and the phantom pain continued to linger. "I tried using my abilities in a new way and suffered a... a backlash, I think it's called. I just need to rest for a bit and my powers will return."

Kiari still looked concerned, but Belial's face relaxed.

"Oh, a backlash? I've heard of that happening before. A few demons in the past tried experimenting with their powers and nearly died from it, but with a bit of rest their strength always returned. You should be more careful, Beelzebub. Remember that backlashes strengthen based on how much power you're trying to release. Whatever you were experimenting with, take it slower next time."

As the oldest demon on the scene, well over 100,000 years of age, Belial had known countless other demons over the years, and even her incidental knowledge was quite vast compared to the other two.

"Did any of them succeed?" Beelzebub asked.

"Of course." Belial answered. "I never saw it personally, but I have it on good faith Ose used to be quite the experimenter back in the day. That's how she developed such a diverse power-set. Not many others actually succeeded though. We demons are pretty limited in what powers we wield, but what we *can* do, we do *well*."

Beelzebub looked unconvinced, but he decided not to argue the point. Belial and Sartran couldn't both be right. Demons couldn't be flexible and inflexible at the first time. Not only that, but Beelzebub had already proven to himself that he could branch out further than what his innate flame powers suggested. His control of electricity was humble, but it was definitely outside the scope of his original abilities.

That made him lean much more heavily toward Sartran's point of view. There must be more he could accomplish!

Beelzebub closed his eyes. He steadied his breathing and fell silent for a while as he waited for his body to recover.

"You guys can go back to town." Kiari suggested. "I'll stay here with Beelzebub until he's all better."

"Alright." Belial said.

She took Cassiel's arm, and the two of them departed, leaving just Beelzebub and Kiari alone again.

"You don't need to stay here and babysit me." Beelzebub said after a minute or two. "I'll be fine after a short breather."

"Maybe. But if you've really lost access to your powers, that makes you vulnerable." Kiari pointed out. "What if Gressil attacked while you were sitting here? Can you say for certain you'd recover before he killed you? I don't... want to take that chance. I don't, um... I don't want to lose you."

Beelzebub paused. He lifted his head and opened his eyes to look up at Kiari, standing before him. When his eyes met hers, she turned away, not wanting to meet his gaze.

"Oh. I see. Then, ah, thank you, Kiari." Beelzebub said, haltingly.

There was a long moment of silence between the two of them. Kiari fiddled with her hair, looking off into the distance while she hovered next to Beelzebub protectively. The trauma of losing her husband had clearly left a mark on her psyche that would not heal anytime soon.

"So." Beelzebub said, after a long few minutes of awkward silence. "How long until the baby...?"

Kiari snapped out of a daze that she hadn't even realized she was in. "The-the baby... I don't know. There's no precedent. Um... humans need nine months, but it seems to be growing fast... it might be next week, or it might be a few months from now."

"Any idea what the baby's gender will be?" Beelzebub asked, though he was only making small talk.

"I don't know. I think I'd rather it be a surprise..." Kiari said softly. "I'd like a boy though."

"A boy would be nice." Beelzebub quietly agreed. "As long as it makes you happy."

Kiari mumbled something under her breath, but even with his keen hearing, Beelzebub couldn't quite make it out. After another minute, Kiari eventually turned around and sat down next to him, wrapping her arms around her legs.

"I know we're in the Cube now..." Kiari said softly. "But I was talking to Sam, and I realized I've been feeling really anxious. Are we going to be okay, Beelzebub?"

"By 'we', do you mean humanity and their allies in general?" Beelzebub asked.

Kiari nodded. She leaned her head forward to rest her chin on her knees. "So much has happened. When I joined the humans, I was only a Lord. I was really insecure about my strength... I still am. I'm an Emperor now but I feel like I haven't been much help. I could save anyone when Tarus II was destroyed. What if the Kolvaxians break into the Cube? Am I going to be useless again?"

"I wasn't any help either." Beelzebub pointed out. "I blew up along with the planet. Then I chased the Volgrim but they still got away."

"No, that's not true." Kiari pointed out. "You killed one of them, right? That Satan-Psion?"

"Sartran." Beelzebub corrected. "And come to think of it, I did end up empowering the Phoenix, so... I supposed I did accomplish a few minor things. The difference is, unlike you, I'm a mass murderer trying to redeem myself. I still fall far short of your accomplishments. You built a lot of houses for a lot of people. You've done more good for these people than I ever have, and probably ever will."

"I don't know about all that..." Kiari mumbled, but she didn't offer much protest to his words.

"There's no sense in worrying about the future." Beelzebub eventually concluded. "Right now, the important thing is to rebuild and focus on improving the current state of affairs. The stronger the humans get, the more likely they'll be to survive future disaster, and maybe even come out stronger afterward."

Kiari smiled faintly. "Yeah... you're always so optimistic, Beelzy..."

Beelzebub rolled his eyes. "Oh, don't call me *that*."

"Hehe, Beelzy!" Kiari chuckled. She flashed a cute smile at him, and Beelzebub's mind momentarily blanked out.

He hadn't realized it before, but Kiari was actually rather... beautiful...

Beelzebub looked off into the distance. The two of them fell silent once again.

They stared up at the distant glowing golden hue of the Cube, wondering what the future had in store for them...

Part 740: Weakest Gamer, Strongest Italian

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

One realspace-day before the Cube successfully swallowed the Sharmur system, back inside the hidden dimension created by the First Wordsmith, a mere two Chrona-weeks had passed.

Previously, Timothy had chosen to unlock the Pawn Summoning System, while Ferral had chosen the Dungeon Creation System instead.

Two weeks was not a lot of time. For Psions, it was practically no time at all. Any Psion worth their salt would have made essentially zero progress improving their fundamental abilities, outside maybe some minor adjustments to a specific psionic application. Perhaps, if they were truly focused, they might have been able to learn a new skill and reach a minor level of accomplishment with it.

But those sorts of Psions were not the same as Ferral. After two weeks of hard work, Ferral had reached Level 7 in the King Network! Each level was important, compounding on the choices made in levels prior. Thus, when Ferral competed against his fellow Psions, the ones who had easily oppressed him before he obtained the King Network, he was able to beat them in singular combat almost half the time!

This was a huge change in status for Ferral. Compared to before when he wouldn't win one out of a hundred fights, now he could even hold his own against Dunal, the publicly recognized strongest young Psion inside Chrona!

Ferral was not the only one who had made great gains. Though she was often busy with other matters, Fiona had advanced to Level 5 and obtained access to the Talent Tree. If she had more time to spare, she probably could have advanced further, but she made up for this lack of leveling speed with a great number of items she had deconstructed and crafted.

Marigold was the last person added to the King Network. Even so, she was level 7! She had obtained several new skills, and had strengthened her body considerably. Unlike the

others, she held little interest in acquiring magical abilities, and preferred focusing on brute force.

Finally, there was the unassuming leader of the group, Timothy Hiro. He had reached level 9, and finally finished up a daily quest with enough EXP to allow him to reach level 10. In this time, he had acquired more than a few skills, and though most were Common or Uncommon skills, he had been very deliberate in picking options that would shore up his weaknesses.

* * *

Timothy Hiro - Human/Chrona

Level 9 | Newbie | Bottom Mortal

Exp: 415/433

HP: 111/111

AP: 2/2 | MP: 25/25

STR 10 | DEX 10

INT 9 | WIS 8

DEF 9 | RES 9

CHA 8 | LUK 10

CON 10 | END 11

* * *

Timothy grinned as he looked at the final Daily Quest that would push him over a five-day hurdle. He accepted the rewards, and his eyes lit up once he saw the words appear before him.

* * *

Level 10 Achieved.

First Reward: Shop System Unlocked.

Second Reward: Choose one of three rewards - [+50 HP] [+1 Basic Stat] [Gain new random Resistance (+10-100%)]

Third Reward: Choose from one of six new Rare skills - [3x Active Skill (Will be immediately usable)] or [3x Passive Skill]

Fourth Reward: Improve two of your skills by +1 levels. You cannot improve the same skill multiple times.

* * *

Timothy was sitting out by a fountain in the middle of town. He jumped up and grinned like an idiot before hopping around excitedly.

"Shop! I got access to the Shop! Finally!! Ohh, this is a milestone! A real milestone!!"

Unfortunately, nobody else was there to share the moment with him, but that was okay. Ferral was training with the other Psions, and Marigold was hanging out with her friends. Naturally, Fiona was busy using her skills to fix things like usual.

Timothy wasn't bothered. He'd been grinding daily quests for five long days to advance from Level 9 to Level 10. He didn't need to share the moment with anyone to be excited himself.

"**Congratulations.**" Umi said, her speck of light flickering into existence with zero fanfare... or *enthusiasm*. "**You have reached the bare minimum milestone to call yourself a Low Mortal. With your current skillset, you are barely a match for the weakest of Demon Lords.**"

Her words were pointed and rude, but that didn't bother Timothy. He had grown used to her way of speaking. Instead, he perked up his ears at the real meaning behind her words.

"Wait, I'm finally on the level of a Demon Lord?" Timothy asked.

"**In the strictest sense, affirmative.**" Umi beeped. She sounded tired. "**After all, you now possess a handful of magical abilities. This is more than some Lords possess. However, there are still many Demons Lords who would defeat you with little effort.**"

Timothy wasn't cowed. "Even if true, that's still amazing! I've been noticing my body felt a little stronger after all my training!"

Timothy's ability to eat and digest food had improved quite a bit as time went on. He'd specially leveled up one of the skills he obtained twice to assist with digestion, allowing him to eat more food and thus increase the workload in the daily quests.

This was important because using the original EXP scaling, he had needed to wait longer and longer between level-ups due to the slowly decreasing relative value of his

daily quest rewards.

* * *

Efficient Eating L3 [Active Skill] [Mundane] [Utility] [6 Hour Cooldown]

The Player gains the ability to digest and absorb the nutrients of any food consumed in the next 15 minutes by an additional 45%. The Player will more efficiently convert their calories and protein into muscle, but can also gain weight much more quickly.

* * *

Not only had the cooldown dropped by a couple of hours, but his digestion efficiency had risen from 20% to 45%. He no longer suffered brutal stomach-aches after eating sessions, and his muscles had more protein to work with as well.

He did fear at first that all this eating would make him fat, but because of all his hard work and training, that fear hadn't come to pass. His body fat level was the same as three weeks ago, before he obtained his powers. More importantly, his muscles had grown to a point that he could actually notice them when he looked in a mirror. He wasn't a bodybuilder by any means, and even his girlfriend looked more muscular than he did, but he had definitely made great strides in his physical development.

Timothy was taller now too. He had grown a full inch, though that was more a result of a late puberty growth spurt than due to his powers.

After Timothy calmed down, he started accepting the rewards.

The first reward was the one he was most excited for, but he decided to put it off for last. Instead, he started by pondering the second reward.

"This choice isn't as easy as it seems." Timothy muttered to himself. "My HP is 111, so +50 is nearly a 50% increase. It's also a nice visible increase. It's easy to see how big of a gain I'll make. But +1 to any Basic Stat is a huge deal too."

The King Network had never offered him this reward before. After all, the system only showed values on a relative scale of 1-20. Therefore, +1 to a stat was actually like taking 1/20th of a step toward the apex power of the galaxy! It had to reflect a massive amount of strength that he could gain. A single +1 was probably way more impactful than +50 HP, especially as he already knew Ferral and Marigold both had 200+ HP.

"Marigold is already way stronger than me. It wouldn't make sense to try and do what she's already doing, but worse. I don't think the HP boost is a good choice." Timothy

reasoned. "But what about obtaining a new Resistance?"

Timothy thought about that option too. Resistances were a huge deal. As a Psion, Ferral had an innate 100% Resistance to suffocation. This meant he could traverse the vacuum of the Void with no threat of asphyxiation, since Psions didn't need to breathe.

But there were all sorts of things one could gain resistance to. What if Timothy rolled somewhat low and 'only' obtained a 25% Fire Resistance? Sure, he wouldn't be immune to fire, but he could stand in sweltering heat a lot more easily, and a burn on his skin would do less damage, not to mention it would hurt less!

A moderate 50% roll could be huge too. Halving the damage taken from an element was a big deal. What if he obtained 50% Physical Resistance? Suddenly an entire arsenal of attacks would barely even make him flinch. Even the full-bodied punch of Emperor Belial might not kill him on the spot! He'd be hurting for sure, but he wouldn't die!

Thus, he had to at least consider the option of choosing a Resistance.

Ultimately though, Timothy shook his head.

"I have a LUK of 10. This is only average. We've confirmed that LUK affects the rolls inside Lootboxes and other such things, which means it would likely affect the roll of my Resistance. Ferral's LUK is actually worse than mine, but Marigold has 15 LUK! So she'd probably have a better time picking this option than me."

With that thought process concluded, Timothy decided to choose to upgrade a basic stat. He hemmed and hawed for a long time.

"Should I try and boost up one of my low-ranking stats? Should I improve on my strengths? Or should I boost something like LUK, which probably won't increase in any way unless I use these meta-means?"

Timothy's highest stat was Endurance at 11. His lowest was a tie between Wisdom and Charisma, at 8.

"My Crocodile Form increases my STR, DEX, CON, and HP by 60% out of water and 120% in water. I still can't use the ability, but that's a huge scaling increase. My Mind of Focus skill raises my INT and WIS by 55%, and I can actually use that skill right now!"

Timothy thought for a long while. In doing so, he made an important discovery.

"How am I being this dense? INT and WIS directly influence my mana. I can use the higher mana to activate stronger skills. I can boost both of them with my Mind of Focus

skill. Furthermore, nobody ever complained about being too smart! It's obvious what my choice should be."

Timothy finally made a choice. He picked INT, elevating it from 9 to 10.

The moment Timothy chose the option, he fell into a daze.

Something changed inside Timothy. He couldn't explain what it was. When he looked around, the world felt... a little different. Not hugely different. It wasn't as if he became a super genius, but he noticed the details of the world around him a little bit more than before.

Going from a 9 to a 10 meant he went from slightly below average to right about the average intelligence of other Sentients in the universe. This meant his general 'smarts' increased by one standard deviation, which was more than most people would gain in a lifetime, but it was also hard to describe with words. Timothy couldn't tell if it had any immediate effects on his current brainpower.

What he could tell was that his Mana suddenly jumped from 25 all the way to 45!

"45 Mana! I nearly doubled it with one stat-up! Now that's a big increase right there!"

Timothy turned giddy with excitement, but he quickly recovered his wits. After that, he chose the third reward, which made six completely different options appear before him.

* * *

Sage's Insight [Active Skill] [Rare] [Utility] [Mana Cost 10] [Cooldown 1 Hour]

Momentarily maxes out WIS for the sake of improving mental flow. Only useful for acquiring answers to troublesome questions. Cannot give answers to questions beyond the ability of the Player, but can spontaneously improve one's creativity for five seconds, allowing them to reach a conclusion they normally might not otherwise.

Divine Blaze [Active Skill] [Rare] [Enchantment] [Mana Cost 1/min (Sustained)] [Cooldown 0]

Enables the Player to temporarily enchant a melee weapon with a light and flame effect that deals a base 50% additional damage to most enemies, and up to 200% extra damage against enemies weak to Fire or Divine attacks. Enemies resistant to both effects will take reduced damage. Remains active on the enchanted weapon until deactivated or until mana is depleted.

Stalking Shadow [Active Skill] [Rare] [Stealth] [AP Cost 1/hour] [Cooldown 1 Hour]

Enables a Player to blend in with the darkness and become nearly invisible to all enemies lacking Darkvision. Player will also gain Darkvision themselves. Beware though, as light will burn the Player in this state, with extreme light dealing heavy damage and potentially leading to Injured states.

Compounding Returns [Passive Skill] [Rare] [Growth]

When training one's body, this skill will grant +10% additional stat growth so long as the training method does not involve the King Network's internal reward structure. Thus if an action would increase a Player's STR stat by .001, it will increase by .0011 instead. This effect is permanent and affects all stats.

Flow State [Passive Skill] [Rare] [Stats] [Toggle]

A Toggle ability that allows the Player to choose from one of three passive bonuses at any given time. These stats can only be swapped if Player is not currently in battle.

Option 1 [Warrior's Physique]: +1 to STR and DEF.

Option 2 [Wizard's Mind]: +1 to INT and WIS.

Option 3 [Wanderer's Fortitude]: +1 to DEX and END.

Universal Translator [Passive Skill] [Rare] [Utility]

Player gains the ability to communicate with any being as long as they are Living or Unliving. Player can speak and write in any language fluently. Player can understand all languages.

* * *

Timothy stared at the six options for a long, long time. He was frozen in shock, completely at a loss with choice paralysis.

"Holy... shit..." Timothy eventually said, though he couldn't seem to get out much more than that. "This... this is the hardest choice of my life!"

The ability to instantly solve any issue that was currently blocking up his brain pathways?

A powerful enchantment ability that would be useful in just about any combat situation?

A stealth ability for avoiding or assassinating strong enemies, sneaking around enemy bases, and otherwise having his way with those who lived in the dark?

Improving all his body's natural gains over time with compounding returns?

An easily toggled option that would boost two of his stats by +1?

Not to mention the ability to understand any goddamn language in the cosmos??

What the hell was he supposed to choose?!

Timothy rubbed his face until his skin turned red. "Bwaaaaahhhhh..."

He didn't even know what noise he made. It was a mixture of elation and despair in tandem. How could he be happy when a choice this difficult was sitting before him now?

"Universal Translator is *soooo* good." Timothy groaned. "Doesn't it mean I could talk to animals? Bugs? Alien empires? Fish? Birds? It literally says *all* living and Unliving things. I can't talk to the dead, it seems, but who cares? Fuuuuuuck, it's such a cool power."

Timothy knew from his mom that his dad had been able to understand any language via his Wordsmithing. It didn't seem like much, but it was genuinely such a practical power that would likely come in handy many times in the future. It was hard not to immediately pick it.

But then, what about the Compounding Returns ability? It didn't seem extreme, but it would definitely add up over time as long as he kept lifting weights.

And! There was another reason he was thinking of picking it.

"I have the option with this level up to strengthen two skills. If I pick Compounding Returns, I can immediately make it stronger and start compounding harder, faster. It's a fantastic synergy."

Buuuuuut...

Timothy grimaced. "The active skills are good too. Not as good as the passives, but my bigger problem is I don't have any really good active skills yet. All I do is choose passive skills, time after time. They're great for not having any requirements, but not so great for making use of my AP and MP. I need a really good combat ability..."

Thus, the enchanted blade skill was also looking really tempting to Timothy.

There were simply too many options. Timothy realized this time he would have to take a pause and ask the other Players for their thoughts. Ferral and Fiona, especially, would have important thoughts on the matter. Marigold... less so. She enjoyed leveling up, but Timothy could tell she wasn't taking it nearly as seriously as he, Ferral, and Fiona were.

That left the Store. Since Timothy wasn't going to pick a skill or level up any skills yet, he finally grinned and tapped the Store button.

Suddenly, Timothy felt his eyes being forced shut. A strange sleepiness fell over him, but he wasn't exactly tired. Instead, his mind drifted off, and his consciousness appeared inside a bazaar of some sort, a place where there were dozens of stalls with people standing in front of them.

"Hey kid! You're the first customer! Come on over here and buy some scrolls!" A fat man with a beard shouted.

"No no, don't listen to that guy, come over here! Helmets! I've got lots of helmets!" Another fat man with a beard shouted.

Timothy blinked twice. He looked around, and realized that at every stall, there was the same guy, over and over, seemingly copy-pasted 800 times. He had the same voice, the same face, but different clothes depending on the stall.

"Uh... what is this place?" Timothy asked, bewildered.

"Haha, you hear that, Giuseppe? This kid doesn't know where he is!" One of the fat men shouted.

"I'm telling you Giuseppe, kids these days ain't got no brains!" Another fat man shouted.

Timothy squinted his eyes. "You're all... named... Giuseppe?"

"No kidding, kid! Looks like you're not as empty in the head as we first thought, eh??" The Giuseppe in front of a book shop said.

* * *

Timothy spent a few minutes walking around. He was complete baffled by the appearance of this completely random duplicated guy who he'd never seen before. Whoever Giuseppe was, he was everywhere!

"...I'm guessing this is the King Network's Shop?" Timothy eventually asked.

"That's right! Hey kid, come on over! I'll sell you a magnifying glass! Just twenty-five gold coins! What'cha say, huh?" Giuseppe asked. "Helps you read books! You like books, kid? Of course you do! Who doesn't like books??"

"Forget that guy, he doesn't know what he's talking about!" A different Giuseppe said. "Come on over here, kid. I've got swords! Fire swords, ice swords, sword-swords, all kinds of swords! All starting at the low-low price of just 4,592 gold coins! It's a steal you don't wanna miss!"

"Matches! Come and spark some matches!" Another Giuseppe shouted. "Light stuff on fire! Burn buildings down! These are Grade-A matches perfect for the enterprising arsonist lookin' to cause some trouble!"

"Magic staffs! Get yerrr magic staffs!" Yet another Giuseppe shouted. "Staff of Magic Missile! Staff of Necrotic Light! Staff of Dick Destruction! All kinds of staffs for a mage wanting to cause mayhem!!"

Timothy closed his eyes. He was starting to feel dizzy from all the shouting.

"I... wait, can everyone just quiet down for a minute? You're all shouting too loud..."

"Oh, sorry, kid." One of the closest Giuseppes said. He quickly lowered his voice. "*Acne poooooowder, come'n git yer acne powder... make a bully break out in zits... just a measly 50 gold...*"

Timothy sighed. He opened his eyes, then wandered from one booth to another. Shockingly, though there was a lot of weird and random stuff here, the sheer breadth of the offerings made him stagger on his feet.

The Shop had everything. Literally everything! Even crazy powerful relics that made his eyes pop!

There was just... one small problem.

"I. Um. I don't have any money." Timothy said sheepishly.

All at once, the entire market fell silent.

"What he said?" One of the Giuseppes asked. "Did I hear this kid right? No money?"

"He's a penniless pauper. Mamma mia!" Another Giuseppe lamented. "Comin' in here, wastin' our time."

"Kid if you ain't got no gold, why you even lookin' around?" Another Giuseppe scolded. "Go kill some monsters and make some money! It ain't that hard! The whole bloody system is built around it!"

"Um... do you guys trade items for gold?" Timothy asked.

"You wanna trade? You got stuff to barter, kid?" Giuseppe, the closest one, asked.

"Not a lot..." Timothy admitted. "I have... uh... lemme check..."

Timothy checked his inventory. He found the Common Longsword he'd picked up in his first week.

"How much for this?" Timothy asked.

The nearest Giuseppe squinted his eyes. He looked at the sword, then directed a look of disgust Timothy's way.

"That... thing? Kid, that's junk. I'll give you five gold coins for it, and that's me being nice!"

"F-five?" Timothy asked, ready to burst into tears. "It's a perfectly good sword though. No damage to it, nice and sharp, good quality steel..."

"If it's that good, then why're you sellin' it, eh? You tryin'a pull one over on ol' Giuseppe?" The fat man asked. "Show me something good!"

Timothy sighed. He put the Longsword back into his inventory, then after a moment, he carefully pulled something else out.

"Um... here's 0.15kgs of Trifrancium... is this worth anyth-"

"HOOOOLY MOTHER OF MEDUSA!" Giuseppe screamed, nearly jumping out of his clothes. "What are you tryin'a do, blow the whole god-damned place to kingdom come?! Put that away, you shit-for-brains! That's way too rare for any of us to mess with!"

Timothy nearly burst into tears again. The sword was garbage, the Trifrancium was too rare. Weren't these guys just deliberately making things difficult for him?

"I... um... I guess I'll come back another time..." Timothy said lamely, as he stuffed the Trifrancium back inside his Inventory.

After a few moments, Timothy deactivated the shop and disappeared, leaving the army of clones behind.

"Kids these days!" Giuseppe exclaimed. "I've heard of playing with fire, but that was ridiculous!"

* * *

Timothy arrived back in Chrona with a splitting headache.

"Good lord... the Shop is not useful to me now at ALL. Quests don't give me any gold either. How the hell am I supposed to earn money so I can buy stuff?"

He remembered what one of the Giuseppes said.

"Don't tell me the only way to earn gold is by killing monsters? If that's the case then... it looks like my peaceful days of grinding daily quests are over!"

Timothy shook his head helplessly.

"Looks like me and Ferral are going to have to run a dungeon. There's no other way. I should talk to him first though... just in case."

With that, he made his decision, turned on his heel, and started strolling southward, toward the Psion Enclave.

Part 741: Psion's Wish

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

When Timothy arrived at the southern Psion Enclave, he heard the unmistakable sounds of combat coming from underground. The Wordsmithium-reinforced walls would not be harmed by the battles of Psions below the 5th Level, but that didn't mean the reverberations of their attacks couldn't be felt outside.

Timothy walked down the stairs to enter the Enclave, and the sounds grew louder. He eventually approached the fighting arena, and he was stunned to see Ferral fighting against two of his fellow Psions! Not just Learner Dunal, who had been his rival since the very beginning, but also Learner Y'ill.

Dunal was something of a brute compared to his peers. He was a blue-skinned Psion who liked to fight using Primal Psionics, the rawest expression of telekinesis possible. He also casually dabbled in Body Enhancing to improve his overall durability.

But Initiator Y'ill was different. She was a gold-skinned Psion who had a deep hatred of the Plague in her heart. She pursued Body Enhancing to the extreme, not seeking to make herself a muscled lunk, but a regenerating monster similar to Beelzebub. Already, at the 2nd Level, she was able to heal her injuries much faster than her peers. She had also become resistant to basic poisons and toxins, as well as acids and the like.

Thus, when she and Dunal fought together against Ferral, Y'ill chose to play the role of Tank, doing her best to stay between the two males, while Dunal fired powerful blasts of telekinesis at Ferral from afar.

Together, the two of them executed a rudimentary form of teamwork, but it was clear they were not used to fighting together. From the sidelines, their teacher, Aspirator Raavul, watched with disapproving eyes.

[Move in tandem with your ally! Cover Dunal's flank so Ferral cannot get behind him. Dunal, you must oppress Ferral with your numerical advantage. You are allowing him to walk all over you! No, no, not like that! Circle back to the right when Ferral moves left!]

Timothy listened from the side. It was easy to tell that Raavul was frustrated by the poor teamwork between Dunal and Y'ill, though it was also clear to Timothy that they

were still easily beating Ferral. The fact he had lasted this long was shocking! No other Psion in Chrona could handle the combined effort of two of their peers.

"When did Ferral become so strong?" Timothy muttered to himself.

Timothy had, of course, been training every day with Ferral and Marigold, but he hadn't been over here to watch Ferral fight the other Psions for a week. And to be fair, it was only one week. Timothy never imagined Ferral had grown so quickly! The last he saw, Ferral had a roughly 50% win/loss ratio against Dunal.

But apparently in Ferral-time, a week was actually an eon. It was clear from Ferral's swift movements and keen analytical eye that he would win way more than half his fights against Dunal now! He was even doing okay against two Psions at the same time!

Eventually, the battle turned sideways when Dunal and Y'ill managed to catch Ferral in a pincer attack. Dunal pinned Ferral down for a brief moment while Y'ill slithered around to Ferral's side and threw a brutal punch to the side of his head, stunning him and knocking him to the floor. With Dunal's help, the two of them managed to pin Ferral to the ground, and Raavul shouted the results.

[Match concluded. Ferral has lost. A total of 1,072 blows were exchanged between both sides. Ferral, you held on longer this time compared to last time. It seems you will be winning these two-pronged engagements in the near future.]

Raavul had technically praised Dunal and Y'ill for beating Ferral, but her voice lacked any sort of pride in them. It was clear she was disappointed in the speed of their growth compared to Ferral. They were being left in the dust by their former weakest peer.

[Well... well fought.] Ferral grunted, as he stood up and clapped his palm first into Dunal's palm, then into Y'ill's. [It appears I need to train even harder.]

Dunal chuckled nervously. [Ah... haha... there is no need to be so aggressive, brother Ferral. We are already barely your match. At this rate...]

His attitude had changed drastically over the last few weeks. In the past, he was the haughtiest Psion present, but these days, his exuberance had dimmed beneath the light of Ferral's glory. Anyone with a brain could see he was envious of Ferral's growth, and slightly depressed due to the lack of comparative speed in his own.

[I'm deeply sorry for that final attack.] Y'ill said to Ferral. [I was at my wit's end trying to come up with a way to beat you. Thus, I chose a cowardly path of attack. It is already

shameful enough that two of us are needed to beat one of you.]

[There is no shame in victory.] Ferral said calmly, as he rested a palm on Y'ill's shoulder. [Do you think the Plague sees any value in the concept of shame? If being underhanded ultimately wins us the war of extinction, then that is how we must act. Your final blow was well-struck. Next time, I will see it coming.]

[I imagine you will.] Y'ill conceded.

After exchanging pleasantries with the other two Psions, Ferral levitated over to Timothy.

[Brother Timothy, it's been a while since you came to see my battles. I am apologetic you had to witness my loss.]

"Ferral, I remember when you had no hope of beating Dunal, and now you're apparently dog-walking him and Y'ill both. They barely beat you. Next time, I bet you'll be the one reigning victorious."

Timothy smiled, imagining his compliment would make Ferral happy. However, he was surprised to see that Ferral's expression remained the same.

[Yes.] Ferral said quietly. [I imagine that soon, none of the other Psions here will be my opponent. Perhaps only the Aspirator will be able to challenge me. And then, after that...]

"Hm? You okay, Ferral?" Timothy asked.

Ferral hesitated. It looked like he was about to say something, but at that moment, a female voice spoke.

[Timothy Hiro. Thank you for coming down here. May I exchange a few words with you?]

Timothy looked past Ferral, where he saw the 3rd Level Aspirator Raavul levitating toward them.

"Raavul?" Timothy said. "You need something?"

As the teacher of Chrona's five other Psions, Ferral, Dunal, Y'ill, Lufa, and Tarim, she commanded a certain level of respect. Thus, when she spoke, Timothy immediately turned his attention to her.

[I apologize for interrupting.] Raavul said. [It came to my attention some time ago that Ferral's speed of Psionic growth had rapidly begun to accelerate. Recently, he has completely eclipsed all my other pupils, and is now leading the entire Enclave by a not insignificant margin. If this speed of growth keeps up, he will likely reach the 3rd Level within one to three Chrona-months.]

Timothy blinked. He didn't say anything, because her words pretty much matched his own observations. If anything, he felt she was being a little conservative.

[I am not too familiar with the concept of the 'King Network', but I have spoken to Rebecca and Blinker about it at length.] Raavul explained. [Timothy, I would first like to thank you for granting one of my students access to this ability. Ferral's strength is Chrona's strength. We are loyal to the Wordsmith, and have no interest in rejoining the Volgrim Empire.]

"Oh, uh, Ferral's my best friend, so... no need for thanks or anything." Timothy said, feeling a little awkward due to her praise.

[I understand he is your closest friend.] Raavul said. [That is why I feel that what I am about to say is a little... presumptuous.]

A long moment passed.

[Timothy, I understand that you have the ability to bring additional people into the King Network. Would you be willing to extend that same privilege to the other juniors of my class?]

Raavul finally got around to asking the question that was on her mind.

Timothy froze.

It wasn't that he didn't see it coming, but he hadn't mentally prepared himself for the question.

"Um... I... I mean... it's not that I *can't*, but there are limited slots available for King Network users..." Timothy said, his tone slightly awkward.

[Slots?] Raavul questioned.

"Yeah. Yes. Um, so basically, when I activated the King Network, I was able to bring four other people into it. I chose Ferral first, then my mom, and then my girlfriend, but now I only have one slot left..."

Timothy quickly explained the general workings of his King Network. Raavul listened silently, her slightly aged eyes contemplating his words.

[I see. And it is impossible to acquire new slots?] She asked.

"No, no, not impossible. But difficult, and rare. I had three chances to add an additional slot over the last two weeks, but I always get offered that choice along with other tangible benefits, so I um... I didn't pick the additional slots. I still only have one available."

Raavul lowered her eyes. [I understand. I was being presumptuous. Please forgive me. In the future, if you should acquire more slots, I would be greatly appreciative if you could extend them toward the other Psions in my class. If you do not wish to, that is naturally your prerogative.]

"No, no, no, it's not that I don't want to, but I should talk it over with the other King Network users first." Timothy quickly explained. "Ask me again in a week or two."

[Of course.] Raavul said, bowing her head. [Ferral, well fought today. Timothy, I take my leave.]

Ravvul turned and left, allowing Timothy and Ferral some time together. Timothy chuckled nervously, then he led his best friend out of the Enclave.

Five minutes passed. The two of them slowly walked in silence toward the western area, where Marigold usually hung out with the other crocodiles.

"I barely managed to hold her off." Timothy eventually said, chuckling quietly. "Don't know if I could pull it off again."

[Hmm?] Ferral grunted, glancing at Timothy from the side of his eyes. [Are you implying with your words that you refused on my account?]

"Well, yeah." Timothy said. "I mean, uh, you know? You *know*, right? If I gave the other Psions access, you'd lose your competitive edge."

Abruptly, Ferral stopped levitating forward. When he stopped, Timothy also stopped, then turned to look at his friend.

[Timothy. I believe you are misunderstanding something about me.] Ferral said, his tone as calm as always. [Do you have a certain belief in your mind that I am afraid of being weaker than the other Psions?]

"W-well, I mean... no...?" Timothy said, though his reply was more of a question than anything else. "But like, um, weren't you always getting bullied by them?"

[Bullied.] Ferral repeated.

A moment passed. Ferral looked away and tapped his chin.

[Bullied. I see. You believe that the taunts of the others were, in a way, oppressing my psyche and causing me harm. You believe that I was in some sort of distress, and that is why I lagged behind them with my Psionic abilities.]

Timothy was at a loss for words. "You... weren't?"

Ferral folded his hands behind his back and returned to looking at Timothy. [No. To clear up this misunderstanding, I will explain. I lagged behind my peers not because they were 'bullying' me, but because I simply lacked all enthusiasm for the art of Psionic Cultivation. Growing my power through meditation, sitting cross-legged for dozens of time-units in a row, and other such methods; these were excruciatingly *boring* to me. I fell behind because Psionics are inherently very, very, very slow and boring to progress.]

[As a result,] Ferral continued, [because I was so slow to grow, the others taunted me. But their words had no impact on my speed of growth in either a positive or a negative sense. I do not value the opinions of others highly. Since I cannot control what thoughts they think or how their opinions of me shift, why should their evaluations matter?]

[Therefore, regardless of whether the other Psions gain access to the King Network or not, regardless of whether they lag behind me in their speed of growth or far outpace me, it will not affect my mental state. I now look forward to growing my strength because I enjoy the feeling of watching my numbers go up.]

Timothy blinked. He looked at Ferral in a new light, realizing he had really been overlooking something important about his friend.

"Oh. Ahaha... I don't know why I thought that then." Timothy said, scratching his head awkwardly.

[I do.] Ferral said. [It is because you yourself have been bullied, and you took the words of other people to heart. When people laughed at you or mocked you, you allowed their words to burrow into your brain and influence your thoughts. This is not too surprising, as many others have fallen into similar mental traps. Since being bullied is

something that deeply affected you, I hypothesize that you believed the same was true of me.]

Ferral shook his head. [If anything, I have started to grow bored of being the only Psion with access to the King Network. I was going to speak to you regarding giving access to the other Psions. I find that having no opponents my equal has quickly started to bore me, and if this keeps up, my growth will stagnate. Think of all the fun games we've played where after defeating the final boss there is nothing fun left to do. That is the future I will soon be facing.]

Ferral chuckled. [Heh. It seems my teacher decided to speak up and save me the trouble. I owe her a word of thanks. Timothy, I do not want to reach the 3rd Level of Psionics and no longer have any worthy adversaries. I cannot and will not force you to pass the power of the King Network to the other Psions, but I would be deeply appreciative if you did. Slots for the Network are indeed difficult to come by, and there are others in Chrona who are just as deserving of this opportunity, so I would completely understand if you had your eyes on other worthy people you planned to uplift.]

Timothy looked away. He fell silent for a while as he thought about what Ferral had said.

"You really want me to boost the other Psions?" Timothy eventually asked.

[That would be appreciated.] Ferral said.

"But then... who should I boost first? Dunal, maybe, since he's your rival?" Timothy asked. "I only have one slot..."

[No.] Ferral said. [I believe the first Psion you should boost is Aspirator Raavul.]

"What? Your teacher? Why her?" Timothy asked, bewildered.

[At the rate my speed of growth is going, I will soon eclipse Raavul's strength.] Ferral said, neither happy nor sad about this fact. [The dignity of a teacher must not be infringed. How could she continue teaching with any sense of pride if all her students eclipsed her? Thus, she should be the next to obtain access to the King Network. Even if no other Psions gain access, having a strong teacher will improve the growth rate of the rest in equal measure.]

"That's a good point. Alright. I'll add Raavul next, if she's okay with it." Timothy agreed.

[Thank you, Timothy. I am always pleased by the amount of trust that you show me.] Ferral said, clasping his hands together in reverence.

"Man, it's nothing, don't get all sappy on me now!" Timothy laughed.

After laughing the misunderstandings off, Timothy and Ferral resumed pacing towards Marigold's house.

"So, the reason I came to get you was because I reached Level 10!" Timothy explained. "I got offered a CRAZY choice and I just can't make up my mind on what to pick. I thought I'd get everyone's opinions first."

Ferral nodded. [A wise decision. What choices were you offered?]

Timothy quickly explained the six options to Ferral, and Ferral fell deep into thought.

[Hmm. Interesting. Sage's Insight, Divine Blaze, Stalking Shadow, Compounding Returns, Flow State, and Universal Translator. I can understand why you are having trouble deciding. The decision would be a lot easier for me, though.]

"It would?" Timothy asked.

[Yes. I am not too interested in Sage's Insight. It doesn't hold much value for me. Compounding Returns is also not too useful, because the System itself already grants me the ability to grow. Growing marginally faster is not as fun or exciting as gaining an entirely new ability. Divine Blaze means little to me as I do not wield a weapon.]

He glanced at Timothy.

[Thus, that would leave for me the options of Stalking Shadow, Flow State, and Universal Translator. Stalking Shadow would grant me an entirely new stealth ability, which is quite desirable. Flow state is interesting in that it would afford me a certain level of versatility. But in truth, of these, I would pick Universal Translator with little hesitation.]

Timothy was surprised. "You would?"

[Yes. I have told you before that my goal is to someday travel the entire galaxy and witness all its sights. Thus, being able to converse with any creature or species across the galaxy would only make my journey that much more exciting. Being able to comprehend their native languages... this ability is exactly the sort of thing I hope to obtain when I level up. In truth, this is the first time I have felt envious of you.]

Timothy nodded slowly. "I see your point. But in terms of an intergalactic war, just being able to talk to people doesn't sound as useful as making myself stronger."

[I am not arguing that you should choose the Universal Translator option. I am only speaking as to what option I would pick. The two of us are different individuals with our own needs.] Ferral explained. [It is also clear to me that the options provided to you were tailored to your needs. I only have one important suggestion.]

Timothy cocked an eyebrow. "Yeah? And what's that?"

[You should not just think of these skills in the current context, but in the context of how they might change as you level them up.] Ferral stated. [Take the Flow State ability. What if elevating it to Level 2 causes it to give +1.5 or +2 to the stated stats instead of +1? That could be a tremendous boon to your combat capability. And how about the Divine Blaze active skill? Wouldn't it become even more potent an offensive ability than it already is?]

Timothy's face scrunched up in concern. "Shit. I was thinking about that a little bit, but now that you mention it... damn. You're not making this any easier for me, Ferral."

[Apologies. I simply wish for you to consider all the options as deeply as possible. I believe your mother will have deeper insights than me, once you explain the choices to her.]

After a few moments, Ferral moved on to the next topic.

[Timothy, there is another matter I have been wanting to bring up for several rotations. Given the choice dilemma before you now, it seems appropriate to mention.]

"Oh? What now?" Timothy asked.

[It is regarding... the speed of our growth.] Ferral said hesitantly. [My strength level is certainly faster than my peers, but of late, I have noticed a dramatic drop in the speed of my leveling. Due to my innate racial passive, I have to work much, much harder to level up than you. As such, daily quests are giving me negligible benefits of late.]

Timothy nodded. Ferral's 'Multiclass Lifeform' passive meant he received 67% reduced experience, thus showing just how devoted he was to leveling up by the fact he was only two levels behind. Even Marigold was slower to level than him, and she didn't have such an issue with her EXP gains.

Timothy had recently noted his own slowed growth. The Quests offered simply didn't provide enough EXP benefits, and the benefits they did provide were worsening over time in relation to their levels.

[Thus, I believe it is time we consider entering a Dungeon.] Ferral concluded. [I have examined the offerings, and Dungeons give far better rewards than Quests, by a significant margin.]

Right now, only Ferral had unlocked Dungeons, so Timothy wasn't too sure on how they worked. Everyone had agreed not to enter them until they were noticeably stronger.

"Can you tell me how they work?" Timothy asked.

[I am not fully certain myself, but I think I should wait to tell you after we have brought along Marigold and gone to meet your mother. The two of them should hear this information as well.]

"Good point." Timothy grunted. "No sense wasting your breath saying it twice."

[But Timothy.] Ferral argued. [Psions do not need to breathe.]

"Oh haw-haw! You know what I meant!" Timothy cackled, as he lightly punched Ferral's arm.

Both men laughed, with Ferral in an unusually good mood after Timothy agreed to uplift the other Psions.

Soon, Timothy would have to make a decision that would affect the future trajectory of who he was as a Hero... and what sort of powers he would wield.

Part 742: Skill Issue

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Not much time later, Ferral and Timothy strolled over into the western area of Chrona, where they found Marigold hanging out with two of her sisters, the three of them laughing together as Marigold babbled excitedly to the other two.

"-can turn into anything! I only have to think about it, and POOF! Just like magic! It's the greatest!"

Timothy blinked in surprise. Crocodiles, both male and female, typically walked around... essentially naked. It was a normal sight, and nobody thought it was weird. Sometimes, Crocodiles would gear up in armor for combat scenarios or for added protection when training. Bodysuits, leather padding, even metal armor in situations like that.

But at this very moment, Marigold and the other two crocodile girls were all wearing dresses! Marigold wore a cute blue sundress that contrasted with her yellow scales, while her blue-scaled sister wore a T-shirt and jean-shorts combo and the red-scaled girl wore an elegant evening dress. The fact all three were wearing completely different outfits that didn't seem suited for any specific occasion seemed somewhat odd to Timothy.

Right as he was wondering what was going on, Marigold waved her hand toward the red-scaled crocodile, causing her evening dress to abruptly transform into a witch outfit, complete with a black frilly skirt and an oversized pointy hat on her head.

"Amazing! And you just have to think about how it looks to make it happen?" The Red croc-girl asked, twirling around and admiring her new outfit.

"Kyargh! That's right! It's easy-peasy! Oh, hey Timmy! I got a great new ability!!" Marigold spotted Timothy and Ferral approaching out of the corner of her eye. She spun to wave at them, causing her skirt to twirl. The movement seemed intentional. "Do you like my dress? Is it cute?"

Timothy nodded and smiled. "It looks great, Marigold. Um, you said you picked a new ability?"

"Yeah!! It's called 'Clothier's Touch'! It lets me put any outfit on anyone as long as I visualize it first! Isn't that cool?!"

She quickly explained all the details of her new ability to Timothy and Ferral.

* * *

Clothier's Touch [Active Skill] [Uncommon] [Equipment] [Mana Cost 0] [Cooldown 0]

Player gains the ability to conjure clothing onto another entity if they consent to the action. Any type of clothing can be summoned, but the clothing will not provide any offensive or defensive value. If the summoned clothing is taken off, it will disintegrate. Clothing summoned by this skill can not be reused for any form of crafting or other purpose and is purely cosmetic.

* * *

"See! Isn't it great? I can change clothes on anyone for free with no cooldown or anything! Talk about a useful skill!"

Timothy's smile wavered. It was clear to him that his girlfriend was really excited about her skill, but in reality... wasn't it mostly useless? It seemed to exist for vanity purposes, since it didn't appear the clothing would even be useful for keeping warm in a winter environment... not that she needed help with that anyway. Chrona had a mild temperature all year long.

[The ability doesn't seem to serve a deep purpose.] Ferral said, immediately voicing his opinion bluntly. [However, as a tool for quickly and conveniently changing one's appearance, I find that it might be useful in certain niche scenarios.]

"Oh, you're such a *guy*!" Marigold laughed. "Only girls would get why this ability is great. What about you, Timmy? Don't you think it's awesome?"

Timothy sighed in his heart, but opted to smile genuinely on the surface. He walked over and kissed Marigold's cheek. "I think the dresses all look really cute."

It wasn't exactly an affirmation to her question, but receiving a compliment clearly made Marigold happy. She giggled at her boyfriend's words, then waved at the other crocodiles. "Okay bye girls! I'll talk later!"

"Bye Marigold!" The other crocs said. "Bye Timothy, bye Ferral!"

Before long, the trio of Players headed back on their way. Timothy thought about asking Marigold what other options she'd been offered, but decided against it. He didn't think the skill she picked was particularly useful, especially since his goal was to become stronger and save humanity someday... but he also didn't think he had the right to dictate what choices she should pick either.

He decided to diplomatically ignore her chosen skill and talk about other things. "So, I have a decision to make between six different skills. I was hoping to get your input along with Ferral's and my mom's."

"Oh really?" Marigold asked. "What skills are they?"

Timothy explained the six skills once again, allowing her to think as they walked.

"Sage's Insight, Divine Blaze, Stalking Shadow, Compounding Returns, Flow State, and Universal Translator. Hmm, a lot of these sound kinda boring. I think the Divine Blaze skill sounds really cool though! Imagine swinging a shiny fiery sword around! Swish-swish, huaah! Oooh!! I could make you a really cool outfit to go along with the sword too!"

Timothy looked down at his current getup. It was simple and plain, a lot like what his father always wore, according to Fiona. A long-sleeved gray turtleneck with some blue jeans. Nothing fancy.

"Uh, I mean, I don't know..." Timothy muttered. "Picking a skill just to look cool?"

Marigold sighed. "Timmy, you're looking at this all wrong. It's not JUST about looking cool. First impressions matter. If you walk around looking dumpy, everyone who sees you the first time is going to *think* you're dumpy! Then you have to work harder to undo that perception! Wearing a good outfit can change how people see you, AND it can change how you think of yourself too!"

Timothy nodded slowly. "I mean... that does make sense."

"Right?!" Marigold asked excitedly. "Here, I'll make you a new outfit! Watch this!"

"I, I uh, I don't know if that's necess-"

Timothy started to object, only for a window to abruptly pop up in front of his face.

[Player Marigold wants to use her skill Clothier's Touch on you. Do you accept the skill?]

There was also a toggle button to always accept or reject the option, but Timothy didn't click either of those. Instead he simply sighed helplessly before pressing 'yes'.

For a brief instant, all of Timothy's clothes vanished, leaving him completely stark naked. A split-second later, a new set of clothes appeared, but the feeling of being suddenly naked made him jump in alarm.

When Timothy looked down, he wasn't entirely sure what he was wearing. He *felt* like he was wearing the same clothes as before. Marigold's skill summoned an illusion of clothing onto his body, appearing on top of his clothes. They didn't provide any additional warmth, and didn't seem to have real weight to them.

When he looked at himself, Timothy found that his turtleneck and pants had both turned completely black. There were slim vertical lines of gold going down from the top of his shoulders all the way down to his shoes, which had also changed into tall black boots.

He couldn't entirely make out what he looked like, but based on the stars in Marigold's eyes, she seemed to think the look was an improvement.

"Wow! Look at what basic color coordination can do for you! I'll make sure you're always wearing something fashionable in the future, okay? No need for thanks!"

"Right." Timothy said. "Um. No need for thanks..."

Before long, the trio arrived at the Spynet Sphere, but for once, Fiona wasn't there. Ferral sensed the emptiness inside with his Psionics, then directed everyone over to Jason Hiro's old warehouse.

When they walked over to visit, the group found Fiona and Rebecca inside, going over all Jason's former projects.

"Oh, Timothy. Hello." Rebecca said, smiling perfunctorily at him. "Ferral. Marigold. What a lovely dress."

"Thank you! Kyargh, I made it myself!" Marigold crowed, clearly pleased by the compliment.

Fiona peeked out from behind a shelf and smiled. "Timothy! Did you need something-oh? What's that outfit you're wearing? That's new. It looks good on you!"

Marigold turned her head to give Timothy the smuggest look a girlfriend possibly could. He ended up sighing helplessly. "Marigold picked up a new skill. She helped me, um, change my look."

"Reaaaally?" Fiona asked, lilting her voice teasingly. "It seems your girlfriend knows how to properly dress a man. You should consult her more often!"

After a few more bits of teasing from the girls, Timothy finally pulled himself back together to explain his situation to Fiona.

"So that's the thing, mom. I have these six skills and I can't decide what to choose. All of them seem useful."

Rebecca continued rifling through Jason's artifacts, but she listened as Timothy explained the details.

"Timothy, didn't you upgrade your main skill recently? That Eye skill?"

Timothy looked at Rebecca. She had a box full of doodads in her lap, and she was sitting on a high stool with her feet up so she could hold the box more comfortably.

"Yeah. Yredelemnul's Eye." Timothy said. "Why?"

He checked his character page and looked at the updated description for the skill.

* * *

Eye of Yredelemnul L5 [Active Skill] [Unique] [Investigation] [MP Cost 0] [AP Cost 0] [Cooldown 0]

The stolen power of a dark god courses through the Player. The Player can examine objects and entities with the Eye of Yredelemnul to learn more information about them. As the Player strengthens, the information available to them will improve drastically.

Improved: The Eye can now see the basic stats of other entities.

Improved: The Eye can sense the auras of powerful life forms.

Improved: The Eye can better see the details of items than before.

Improved: The Eye can peer into unsealed files and perceive their full contents instantly.

* * *

Over the last couple of weeks, whenever Timothy was offered the option to upgrade a skill, he always considered improving the Eye, since it was a potent skill that gained powerful new abilities each time, and it was completely free to activate anytime he wanted.

The Level 4 upgrade had allowed him to pick up way more details of items in the world than before. He had even used it to catalog some of his father's artifacts, but he hadn't gone through all of them yet.

The Level 5 upgrade was especially useful. He could use the skill to read any book instantly, to watch any movie instantly, and essentially to convert any form of hard media into knowledge inside his brain. Unfortunately, outside of his dad's old movie collection, Chrona didn't exactly have a lot of books or other knowledge artifacts lying around, so it wasn't too useful at the moment.

"I think you've been undervaluing that Level 5 upgrade." Rebecca said. "Think about how it might work with the Universal Translator. You could look at Volgrim artifacts and instantly understand them in their entirety. You could study books and other such things from the demons, goblins, orcs, and so on. Unlike the translation devices the Volgrim or Marie Becker use, you'd have the ability to understand all languages innately. That's a pretty big deal."

"I thought so too." Timothy said. "Ferral also thought choosing Universal Translator would be the best option. But we do have another consideration..."

He looked at Ferral, and Ferral took a step forward.

[My speed of leveling has drastically slowed, as of late.] Ferral said, spreading out his hands. [Using only quests provided by the King Network, my ability to level is going to slow more and more. I believe it is time for us to consider entering Dungeons. Since that is the case, we should strongly consider combat-focused skills and items to prepare for our first foray into the unknown.]

Fiona immediately frowned. "Dungeons? That sounds really dangerous! Timothy's never fought anyone in his life! Neither has Marigold. Even you, Ferral, you've only ever sparred with the other Psions. You'd be putting all your lives in danger if you stormed into a Dungeon looking for trouble!"

Fiona was not unfamiliar with Ferral's ability. He had already elaborated on how it worked to her and the others in the past, so she knew the entire point was to enter a dungeon and kill monsters to acquire loot.

But the concept of a dungeon in a video game was very different from entering one in real life. Fighting was dangerous. The winner would likely end up with bruised knuckles

at the very least, and plenty of other injuries at the worst. The loser would end up beaten and bloody, if not dead. There were no winners in a fight!

At least, that was the conventional logic. When 'loot' entered the picture, the equation did change...

[It is possible to continue leveling safely so long as we merely spend a long period of time doing daily quests and other such things.] Ferral said. [However, due to increasing EXP requirements per level, there will be increasingly longer intervals between level-ups. Eventually, the time needed to acquire improvements will reach a point where months or years pass with minimal gains. This is especially burdensome for me, as I suffer a huge penalty due to my species characteristics.]

Fiona rubbed her temple as she fell into thought. "I understand what you mean. And it's clear Timothy isn't going to stop doing dangerous things, so the lot of you are probably going to enter Dungeons no matter what, right?"

Timothy slowly nodded. "We have to do this, mom. I *want* to grow stronger. I want to become a great Hero, like my dad. Humanity is fighting a battle for its extinction out there... and maybe if I level up quickly, I can gain the power to save Chrona as well! If not me, maybe Ferral or Marigold? We don't have the luxury of sitting around on our butts!"

Fiona sighed. "Yes. I get the point. Alright, alright, fine. Going into Dungeons... it's probably a necessity. BUT! I am not letting you walk into a dangerous situation untrained! I expect all of you to engage in real, serious combat training beforehand! If any of you flinch in the face of mortal danger, I won't let you go."

Timothy cocked his head. "I mean, that's a great idea mom, but what kind of training should we do?"

"The Queen Network is the best option, but I don't have time to fix it." Fiona said. "So, it seems I'll have to pester Blinker into training you."

"Aunt Blinker?" Timothy asked. "I mean, she's strong as hell, but why *her* specifically?"

"Blinker can summon illusions with physical mass. She's *very* good at it." Fiona explained. "She'll whip you three into shape. I can't go with you into the Dungeons. I'm too busy. So it'll have to be just the three of you."

Timothy tapped his chin. "Unless I can add someone else to the group. Maybe we can bring along another Psion?"

He thought about Ferral's suggestion to add Aspirator Raavul to the King Network. If Timothy did so, then they would have an even stronger Psion than Ferral on their side. Not a bad idea, all things considered.

The problem was, if Ferral already had a 67% EXP reduction, than how much of a reduction would his teacher end up with?

Blinker would probably suffer an EXP and loot reduction of 90% or more if she were added to the King Network. That was the biggest thing holding Timothy back from inviting her. He'd otherwise love to add a fairy powerhouse to the team.

Unfortunately, Dungeons could only be entered by Players at first. Only if the Dungeons broke and erupted into the real world would non-Players like Blinker be able to enter. If that weren't the case, then Blinker could come along and assist the team without even being in the King Network. That was likely the reason why non-Players were banned.

"Alright. So Aunt Blinker can teach us how to fight." Timothy said, nodding. It was a great idea, because he was feeling apprehensive at the thought of entering Dungeons unprepared. No doubt, he wanted to earn loot badly, but he hadn't ever actually gotten in a fight before and he was understandably a little scared.

[I also approve of training with Blinker. I hope she is able to push me to my limits.] Ferral agreed.

"Yeah, sure, sounds fun!" Marigold said. She didn't seem as jazzed about it as the men, but she was plenty interested in her own right. It was only that, unlike Timothy and Ferral, her priorities were less about 'saving the galaxy' and more about having fun with her powers.

"Good." Fiona said.

She turned her attention back to Timothy. "Well, regarding your six skills... I agree with Rebecca. You should pick the Universal Translator power. Not only because of all the previous reasons outlined, but because of the fact it will likely assist you in the Dungeons. What if you end up facing enemies who speak a weird language? You'll be able to understand them, and either negotiate for passage, or at least understand their plans as they shout out to one another. It would provide a tactical advantage."

Timothy nodded. He also frowned a little, because he felt discounting all the other skills wasn't a good idea. "Mom, what would your second choice be?"

"That's simple." She said. "I'd pick Flow State. The ability to swap around two core stats at any point is huge, plus if you upgrade your skills, this one has the most utility. You won't be locking yourself into a combat style for the future. We humans are supposed to be adaptable, after all."

Timothy nodded. It turned out he and his mom were on the same level.

He really wanted to pick Divine Blaze, just to have a solid offensive skill with some utility. However, gaining an entirely new ability with Universal Translator was just too tempting to pass up. He'd surely have other options for offensive skills in the future.

After thinking for a bit, Timothy reached into his Inventory and pulled out two Lock Token items. He only had five of them, but these skills seemed important enough that in the future, he would want to pick them if he had a choice.

Thus, Timothy chose to lock Divine Blaze and Flow State in place. In the future, if he acquired a Rare Lootbox, or if Rare Skills were ever offered, one or both of these two would appear first. That would ensure he could pick the skills he wanted most!

With that, Timothy made his decision. He chose Universal Translator.

* * *

Universal Translator [Passive Skill] [Rare] [Utility]

Player gains the ability to communicate with any being as long as they are Living or Unliving. Player can speak and write in any language fluently. Player can understand all languages.

* * *

Now, Timothy only had one last choice to make. Which two skills would he upgrade?

Typically, Timothy would upgrade Yredelemnul's Eye, then he would upgrade another skill. But this time, he decided to pass on the Eye.

"I need combat options badly. I only have one good combat skill, but I can't use it yet. Crocodile Form is Level 3 now... what if I got it to Level 4 or even 5? Wouldn't I be able to use it pretty soon? Plus the effect is really good too..."

Timothy looked at Crocodile Form.

* * *

Crocodile Form L3 [Active Skill] [Rare] [Transformation] [Holistic] [80 Mana (Sustained) OR 8 AP (Activated)] [No Cooldown]

The Player gains the ability to transform into a half-crocodile, gaining all the upsides and downsides that come along with such a transformation. Their skin will become hardened and scaled, granting bolstered defense. Their muscles will increase in density. They become incredibly adept in water. However, their mind will slow down somewhat. The player can revert back to their original form for free at any time.

Grants +70% STR, DEX, CON, and HP, with doubled improvements when in water. Grants -40% INT and WIS.

* * *

He had already leveled it once again in the last two weeks, but he hadn't yet gotten to a point he could use it. As a Rare Skill, it was extremely powerful. He could become a serious fighter even without any other weapons and armor, provided he was able to activate this skill.

"Alright. I'll level up Crocodile Form again, then... you know what? Let's try leveling Universal Translator once, just to see what happens?"

While Timothy messed around with his Player skills, the others patiently waited to see what would happen.

Bloop! Bloop!

Timothy leveled both his skills, and the results appeared a moment later.

* * *

Crocodile Form L4 [Active Skill] [Rare] [Transformation] [Holistic] [70 Mana (Sustained) OR 7 AP (Activated)] [No Cooldown]

The Player gains the ability to transform into a half-crocodile, gaining all the upsides and downsides that come along with such a transformation. Their skin will become hardened and scaled, granting bolstered defense. Their muscles will increase in density. They become incredibly adept in water. However, their mind will slow down somewhat. The player can revert back to their original form for free at any time.

Grants +80% STR, DEX, CON, and HP, with doubled improvements when in water. Grants -35% INT and WIS.

Universal Translator L2 [Passive Skill] [Rare] [Utility]

Player gains the ability to communicate with any being as long as they are Living or Unliving. Player can speak and write in any language fluently. Player can understand all languages.

Improved: Player can communicate with the Dead, provided the corpse is less than 24 hours old.

* * *

Timothy stared blankly at his new skills for a moment. His expression turned awful.

"Well... I still can't use Crocodile Form yet, but... the improvement to Universal Translator makes me feel kind of gross. I can talk to corpses now..."

"Corpses??" Marigold asked, recoiling in horror. "*Eww*! Gross! What's the point of doing that?"

Fiona grimaced. "A bit morbid, for sure. But... I suppose if someone were killed, you could ask them... who their killer was?"

"Great. I can play detective and hunt down serial killers." Timothy said, rubbing his face. It was certainly a strong upgrade in terms of utility, but he wasn't sure he'd want to hear murder victims detailing the manner in which they were killed. The thought made his stomach curdle in disgust.

He only had 45 mana, so he was still a ways off from being able to transform into a Crocodile, but he was a lot closer than before!

Now that he'd completed all his level-up tasks, Timothy thought about what he should do next. The answer was obvious.

"I guess we should go look for Aunt Blinker and see if she'll help train us."

"Heck yes! Let's get stronger so we can go into Dungeons!" Marigold chirped, pumping her fist excitedly into the air.

[I concur.] Ferral added, his tone much more neutral. [But shouldn't we add my teacher to the King Network first?]

"No rush on that. Let's see what Blinker has in mind first." Timothy said. "If she's too busy, we might end up asking Raavul to train us instead."

[A fair point.] Ferral replied.

After discussing some other miscellaneous matters, the trio finally left the warehouse...

"We're so close, I can almost taste adventure!" Marigold laughed.

Part 743: Timothy's Transformation

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

On the way over to the southern Psion Enclave, Timothy and the others paused their walking to turn and look to the side. There, they found the only demon presently inside Chrona walking over to them, each hand holding a bag with a cardboard box inside it.

"Master Timothy, I finished preparing today's meal." The demon said.

"Awesome! Thanks a bunch, Paimon!" Timothy said, grinning at the well-dressed demon as he approached.

Paimon had been summoned by Timothy's Pawn Summoning system, but unfortunately, as he was a Pawn, he could not level up or grow any stronger like the other four. Thus, he was unable to train and improve his strength over time.

He wasn't exactly weak, but Paimon was only a Demon Grunt, a Burrower with the ability to manipulate rocks and soil. This meant in the future, he would inevitably fall behind the core three Players, and that caused Paimon to worry he would become irrelevant.

As such, Paimon revealed one of his non-combat skills. It turned out he was a decent chef who had served other higher-ranking demons! His culinary skills weren't on the level of someone like Chef Yamir, but he could whip up decently tasty food sufficient to meet Timothy's daily quest requirements.

At the same time, he also took the initiative to make food for Marigold too, and she was extremely appreciative! He even took her preference for meat into account. Paimon couldn't make food for Ferral, since he didn't need to consume anything, but at least he felt he had a purpose now.

With Paimon's arrival, Timothy and Marigold decided to sit down and have a quick lunch with a simple picnic spread. Since Ferral couldn't eat food, he decided to move on to the Enclave to fetch his teacher and bring her back. Thus, Ferral left the human, crocodile, and demon together.

Paimon sat on Timothy's right side, while Marigold sat across from Timothy. Before long, the three of them started talking and laughing as they recounted their day.

"Master Timothy," Paimon said, "I was speaking to one of the crocodiles earlier and suggested that I could remodel the surroundings of the Swimming Hole. It's quite bland, don't you think? Some more amenities to pass the time, such as slides, could give it a more fun-filled air."

"That's a great idea!" Marigold exclaimed. "It's just a big hole filled with water right now. Could you maybe add lots of little cavities underwater and other stuff like that for hide and seek?"

"Of course." Paimon said, pressing his palm over his heart. "It would be my pleasure."

Timothy took a big bite of a sandwich filled with peppers and steak. Part of the sandwich dripped out the back and landed on the napkins in front of his crossed legs.

"Damn, that's a good sandwich." Timothy mumbled between bites. "Ah right, Paimon, the three of us are thinking of going into a Dungeon for the first time."

"A Dungeon?" Paimon asked. "Don't you think it's a little early for that? It sounds quite dangerous, considering your current strength."

"We won't know until we try." Timothy said. "But um, I was debating whether or not we should take you. I figured I'd ask if you wanted to go."

"Of course I do. Your safety is my primary concern." Paimon said. "As of right now, I'm still at least a little stronger than you. I'm not a pushover, you know."

"Yeah, true, but... I don't have any way to make you stronger..." Timothy said hesitantly. "It would be great if you could level up, but that doesn't seem possible."

"Mmm. Indeed, that is a problem." Paimon muttered. He rubbed his palm beneath his chin. "Master, I have considered another possibility. Can I don equipment from your Inventory?"

Timothy blinked. "I... I don't know. That's a good question. Here, take this."

The young man opened his Inventory. Inside, he saw various good he'd acquired over the last few weeks. He still had the Octopus Armor which he wasn't wearing at the moment, and the common Longsword. He pulled the sword out and handed it over to Paimon.

Paimon took the sword. It didn't dissipate in his hands, so he stood up, backed away a little, and swung it around.

"It seems my conjecture was correct. Master, if you can acquire gear for me, I can become at least a little stronger and join you in Dungeons."

"I don't have much right now though..." Timothy said hesitantly. "All the gear I have is meant for me."

"I should still come along anyway." Paimon said, as he sat down and handed the sword back to Timothy. "Low level earth manipulation might not sound impressive, but I can bury an enemy's foot underground to trip them up, or fling rocks at them with extreme force. I can bring a ceiling down if needed. I won't be much use fighting at the front, especially when Miss Marigold is the sturdiest member of our group, but I can be of great assistance in the rear."

Timothy nodded. "We'll bring you along, then. I can probably get my mom to make us some armor first. Something basic to meet our needs. It's not like the King Network rejects real items."

As Timothy said that, his eyes momentarily glazed over. He blinked twice. "Wait... isn't that the solution? My dad made all sorts of artifacts, and my mom is pretty busy now but we still have machines that can forge stuff. Maybe we can outfit ourselves with proper equipment before we go into a Dungeon to ensure our safety!"

Marigold cocked her head. "Huh! Now that you mention it, that's a great idea. Kinda obvious in hindsight. Good thing you thought of it before we actually went in!"

The trio burst into laughter, realizing they hadn't thought of something so obvious already. In truth, while Timothy did think of the full idea, he wouldn't have done so without Paimon's previous question. This just went to show how they were a lot better off as a group than they were individually.

Some times later, once the food was almost fully consumed, Timothy looked at his Daily Quest. He'd already done all the workout parts of the quest, and with Paimon's big meal, the food part of the quest was also finished too.

* * *

[Side Quest] [Repeatable] Train Your Body!

Small gains compound over time. Perform a series of exercises, with increasing rewards depending on how many repetitions you can complete. To complete this Quest

properly, you must complete each type of exercise in one session each. You may not space them out across the day, or across multiple days.

[Complete Pushups 100/100] Rewards: 1x Tier 1 Lootbox.

[Complete Pullups: 100/100] Rewards: 1x EXP per 3 Pullups. 100th Pullup grants 5 EXP.

[Complete Situps: 100/100] Rewards: +2.5% END, +2.5% CON.

[Complete Squats: 100/100] Rewards: 1x Mundane Skill Lootbox.

[Complete Long Jog: 10/10 Km] Rewards: +5% maximum movement speed.

[Swim Session: 10/10 Km] Rewards: +2.5% swimming speed.

[Eat Cooked Meat: 1.5/1.5 Kgs] Rewards: +2.5% Gut Digestion.

[Eat Vegetables: 1.5/1.5 Kgs] Rewards: +2.5% Eyesight Improvement.

Note: If the Player completes all Quest objectives within 24 hours, all rewards will be doubled. This Quest may be completed once per 24 hour period.

* * *

Each time Timothy did his Daily Quest, he would save up the lootboxes for later, while accepting all the other rewards. As such, his ability to digest food had grown around two times stronger than before he obtained the King Network. He could power through the daily quest's food requirements with great ease now, and while he couldn't really tell how much his eyesight had improved, he was able to see the individual leaves on trees a full block away.

He was also a much faster swimmer now, though Marigold's swimming prowess had started at a higher point and she was still far faster than him.

Timothy looked inside his inventory. After acquiring today's daily rewards, there was a stack of 30x Mundane Skill Lootboxes he hadn't opened yet, and a stack of 30x Tier 1 Lootboxes he also hadn't opened.

There was a good reason he hadn't opened them. It was because Umi had told him if he took three identical Lootboxes, he could merge them together into a Lootbox of one tier higher.

He wasn't sure if he wanted 30 common skills or 10 uncommon skills, or 3 rare skills and 1 uncommon skill, or maybe even a single Legendary skill. He had a hard time

making that decision.

Marigold was the same as him. Players couldn't exchange their Lootboxes, or else Timothy would immediately hand them all over to his mom to open. Her passive granted +1 item when opening any lootbox, so that was a huge benefit Timothy couldn't reap the benefits for.

"I think it's time to open my lootboxes." Timothy said quietly. "After thinking about it, I've decided to merge all my skill lootboxes, but just use the Tier 1 lootboxes as-is."

Marigold shrugged. "If you think that's a good idea, then go ahead! Kyargh! I kinda just wanna open all mine as-is anyway."

Timothy nodded. Since they were still waiting for Ferral to return, Timothy decided to start cracking the lootboxes open.

When the first Rare Skill Lootbox opened, Timothy was not surprised by what he saw. He had, after all, locked two skills in place from his previous level up options. But in addition to those, there was another...

* * *

Divine Blaze [Active Skill] [Rare] [Enchantment] [Mana Cost 1/min (Sustained)] [Cooldown 0]

Enables the Player to temporarily enchant a melee weapon with a light and flame effect that deals a base 50% additional damage to most enemies, and up to 200% extra damage against enemies weak to Fire or Divine attacks. Enemies resistant to both effects will take reduced damage. Remains active on the enchanted weapon until deactivated or until mana is depleted.

Flow State [Passive Skill] [Rare] [Stats] [Toggle]

A Toggle ability that allows the Player to choose from one of three passive bonuses at any given time. These stats can only be swapped if Player is not currently in battle.

Option 1 [Warrior's Physique]: +1 to STR and DEF.

Option 2 [Wizard's Mind]: +1 to INT and WIS.

Option 3 [Wanderer's Fortitude]: +1 to DEX and END.

Transformaster [Active Skill] [Rare] [Toggle] [HP Reduced by 25%]

When this skill is toggled, any skills that transform a part or the entirety of the user's body have 50% reduced activation requirements. This skill will remain active until toggled off. The user will lose 25% of their max HP, which will remain reserved until the skill is toggled off. If Transformaster is toggled off, any skills that do not have their requirements met as a result will also toggle off.

* * *

Timothy's eyes nearly popped out of his head. His jaw fell open as he saw not only the previous two Rare skills he had intended to choose, but a new one as well!

"Holy crap!" Timothy exclaimed. "I hit the jackpot! This is exactly the skill I need!!"

He still wanted to choose Flow State, and Divine Blaze was definitely a good skill as well, but this new passive immediately solved a huge problem for him! With it, he could activate Crocodile Form! It also meant if he had a chance to obtain other transformations in the future, he could wield them immediately as well!

"What is it? What'd you get?" Marigold asked.

Timothy grinned. He didn't hesitate and chose the Transformaster skill. A moment later, Timothy activated it, causing his body to feel a little weaker. His maximum HP fell from 111 to 83, but so did the costs for activating Crocodile Form!

* * *

[Active Skill] [Rare] [Transformation] [Holistic] [35(70) Mana (Sustained) OR 3(7) AP (Activated)] [No Cooldown]

The Player gains the ability to transform into a half-crocodile, gaining all the upsides and downsides that come along with such a transformation. Their skin will become hardened and scaled, granting bolstered defense. Their muscles will increase in density. They become incredibly adept in water. However, their mind will slow down somewhat. The player can revert back to their original form for free at any time.

Grants +80% STR, DEX, CON, and HP, with doubled improvements when in water. Grants -35% INT and WIS.

* * *

With his MP now at 45, he was within the range to activate the skill. As such, instead of answering Marigold, Timothy chose to stand up and enable Crocodile Form.

Timothy's body shone with a brilliant light, causing Marigold and Paimon to wince. Within two seconds, Timothy's figure started changing. His head shifted and deformed. His mouth elongated dramatically. His arms and legs thickened, and scales grew over his body.

He went from a pale-skinned human to a grey-scaled Crocodile, rising another foot in height!

But, just as soon as the transformation finished, Timothy lost his balance.

"Guhh, guhh!!"

Timothy tried to cry out in warning, but his face felt so heavy that he could barely open his mouth. At the same, time, the way his snout 'felt' was wrong, and made him start choking. All that weight at the front of his body made him lose his balance and he fell forward onto his stomach, causing his snout and the front-most part of his jaw to painfully *clap* against the ground.

"Aaaugh! Aaah, huugu, guuh!"

Timothy growled out some sounds that did not come out as words. He had narrowly avoided falling on top of his girlfriend, but suffice it to say, his first transformation into a Crocodile was... anything but elegant.

Marigold got up, then walked over to try and help Timothy up. "Timmy, are you okay? Did you bite your tongue? Here, help me get him up, Paimon!"

The two of them worked together, demon and Crocodile, and helped Timothy stand up.

Timothy tried to speak, but he could not properly make his huge, unwieldy mouth work properly. "Guhh, shlaaaw waaah..."

Timothy felt so embarrassed that he wanted to crawl in a hole and die. He'd finally been able to transform into the same species as his girlfriend, but he felt like a complete loser in front of her too. He wished he'd transformed in private first so he hadn't embarrassed himself.

Luckily, Marigold seemed to understand what the problem was. "I don't know how it is for you humans, but we crocs don't talk with lips and tongue. We talk with the back of our throats! You'll probably need to practice a bit to talk right, I guess..."

Marigold had never really thought about what a huge difference it would be to transform into a completely different species. Now that she pondered the matter, would she look like a dummy if she obtained a human transformation skill? Would she drool all over herself, trying to get her lips working properly?

Timothy opened and closed his mouth with great effort. To him, it felt as if he had to bend his jawbone in half just to open his mouth a few inches. It wasn't *exactly* painful, but it was extremely uncomfortable, like nails on a chalkboard. It was almost as if he could feel the bones in his jaw scraping against each other. On top of that, his mouth felt extremely moist, as if he had much more saliva sloshing around than usual.

And his tongue! Timothy's long tongue felt completely alien in his mouth. It lacked the sensitivity and the sense of taste he was used to. His eyesight felt duller, and even his mind seemed to be working much more slowly than usual. That was likely due to the reduction to his INT and WIS stats.

Timothy blinked his eyes heavily. It was only now, after he obtained the ability he'd been hoping to get for such a long time, that he realized transformations were not what they were cracked up to be.

Even though Marigold didn't seem thrilled about his clumsiness, it was clear she really liked his new transformation!

But Timothy didn't. He'd only been in his new body for one minute and he already *hated* it.

How could he tell Marigold he didn't like being a crocodile? Simply looking at her face, she was clearly excited to see him in this new form. Timothy also felt that after working so hard and putting so many levels into becoming a Crocodile, it wouldn't make any sense for him to immediately shelve it. He's already leveled it up three times!

If only he knew how much he'd hate being a crocodile, he would have avoided it from the very start. To him, this was body horror, plain and simple, like waking up in the body of a monster. It was utterly dreadful.

"Well? How is it?" Marigold asked. "How do you like being a crocodile?"

Timothy's eyes felt heavy.

"Muuhh, mulnn phlahhh..."

His tongue fell out of his mouth, and he had the damnedest time trying to get it back in. No matter how Timothy tried, the stupid tongue would not listen to his commands. He eventually had to grab it with his claws and push it back inside.

After seeing Timothy struggle for five long minutes, the excitement dimmed inside Marigold's eyes. She wasn't blind, and she wasn't stupid. She could tell he was really struggling.

"Hey... you can turn back into a human if you want..." Marigold said hesitantly. "It's okay if becoming a crocodile isn't working out for you. I already told you I like you just the way you are."

Timothy heaved a sigh. He had tried to sound enthusiastic, but even Marigold could tell he was absolutely awful at being a crocodile.

After another minute of deliberation, Timothy finally deactivated the skill. He transformed back into his original self and sagged to his knees. He felt exhausted. The pressure on the base of his skull from how huge his snout was had left him with phantom pain and a neck kink he couldn't get out.

"Uhh... I'm sorry... Marigold." Timothy said tiredly. "That felt... really weird. I'll try practicing some more in my free time."

"You don't have to force yourself." Marigold said, her tone quiet. "It's fine."

She sounded a little defeated, which made Timothy feel awful. He felt as if he had tried to engage with someone regarding their favorite hobby, only to fumble the interaction so badly that both participants lost all their enthusiasm. It was a feeling one could only understand if they had ever screwed up a social interaction in such a broadly pathetic manner.

Marigold sat back down to finish the last bit of her food. She smiled at Paimon. "Thanks Paimon. The meal was really delicious."

Paimon smiled back. "Anything to make you happy, Miss Marigold."

Timothy dazedly stared at his inventory. The newest Rare skill he'd acquired, along with the Crocodile Form L4 skill, seemed to be looking back at him mockingly. He'd spent quite a lot of effort to acquire and upgrade these skills, but now he felt he'd wasted his time. He had plenty of other skills he could have leveled up in that same time, but he'd

passed on them to focus on the skill he thought would be most badass and make his girlfriend happy.

Now he felt like an idiot.

The worst part wasn't even the disappointment or the lost time and energy. It was that he really did not enjoy the *feeling* of being a Crocodile. Every part of the experience felt like an alien had infected his body and taken over his consciousness. He simply didn't want to become a Crocodile ever again, not even to practice and try to make it work.

If this was how bad the Crocodile Form made him feel, then what about the Octopus Form?

Timothy looked up the Octopus Armor.

* * *

Octopus Armor [Item] [Uncommon] [Torso] [Balanced]

A versatile set of armor that grants the Player the ability to camouflage themselves when underwater, blending in with their surroundings. When camouflaged, the Player effectively doubles their remaining oxygen, but cannot move. The Player also passively heals 1% of their Max HP every minute underwater when wearing this armor.

Comes with Active Skill: Octopus Form [Active Skill] [Uncommon] [Transformation] [Offense] [5(10) Mana (Sustained) OR 1(1) AP (Activated)] [No Cooldown]

Octopus Form sprouts six tentacles out of the Player's back. It allows the user to wield multiple additional weapons, up to six 1H weapons or three 2H weapons, in addition to the Player's base two limbs. The Octopus Tentacles cannot be controlled by the player and are fully automated. The player can revert back to their original form for free at any time.

* * *

Timothy thought for a moment. He realized the Octopus Form was nowhere near as body-changing as the Crocodile Form. With that in mind, and since he still had 10 MP left, Timothy gritted his teeth and decided to test the form out.

A second later, Timothy's body shone with another brilliant light. All of a sudden, six long octopus tentacles emerged from his back.

Even though Timothy had already been able to activate the Octopus Form for the last couple of weeks, ever since his near-death scare at the swimming hole, he'd avoided touching the armor. Now that he was trying out the transformation, he realized it actually... felt pretty good!

It wasn't bad at all!

The octopus limbs certainly felt a little weird, and the idea that six new 'arms' were sticking out of his back made him a little uncomfortable, but compared to the Crocodile Form, the Octopus Form was way more manageable!

Timothy stood up. He nearly fell backward from the extra weight, but two of the tentacles helpfully pressed against the ground to stabilize his movements. Timothy started walking around, threw a few punches, and experimented with lashing out with one of the tentacles at a time, then two, then three. He wasn't able to control them the same way he would his actual arms, but if he wanted to do something, the tentacles would follow his orders as if he were a movie director commanding his subordinates to execute tasks.

By the time Ferral was on his way back, Timothy had already started adapting to the Octopus Form. He felt that, in hindsight, this transformation was insanely strong. It basically had no drawbacks outside of looking a little weird, and he felt like his threat level had increased substantially!

"Wow, you're pretty good with those!" Marigold said encouragingly.

Even though she was saddened by Timothy's obvious rejection of the Crocodile Form, the fact he had adapted so easily to the Octopus Form hinted that maybe he'd be able to try again someday and actually do really well as a crocodile! It gave her hope, and she latched onto that with fervent desire.

While Timothy experimented, Ferral levitated toward them, his teacher Raavul following closely behind. Seeing Timothy in his transformation, Ferral glanced at him.

[Are you having fun?] Ferral questioned.

"More than I was just a bit ago." Timothy said. "Ah, Raavul. You're here. Did Ferral explain why he wanted you to come over here?"

Raavul bowed her head and blinked all of her eyes in unison.

[Yes. It seems that you wish to make me a Player in your King Network. This was not what I had in mind when I asked you before... but Ferral managed to convince me this was the right way to do things.]

[A teacher's dignity must not be infringed.] Ferral said, repeating the same words he'd said to Timothy previously. [If things had shaken out properly, you should have been the first Volgrim Timothy invited. As things are now, being the second is not such a bad result. Hopefully, we will be able to add the others as Players next, once Timothy earns more slots.]

Timothy nodded. "That's the plan. So, Raavul, are you ready to join us?"

The teacher of the Psions slowly nodded her head.

[In truth, I have little interest in this system of yours. However, I cannot deny the power and benefits it has brought Ferral. If we are to prevent the collapse of Chrona someday, spatial Psionic power may end up becoming a core component of stabilizing our home.]

She didn't seem excited to become a Player, but Timothy sensed she would at least take the system seriously. As such, he opened his player sheet and looked at the last available Slot before tapping it with his finger.

"Welcome to the King Network, Raavul."

[AN ADMINISTRATOR IS INVITING YOU TO THE KING NETWORK.]

[IF YOU ACCEPT THIS REQUEST, YOU WILL BECOME A **PLAYER**.]

[WILL YOU ACCEPT THE FRIEND REQUEST AND JOIN TIMOTHY HIRO'S PARTY?]

[YES | NO]

After a moment's hesitation, Raavul pressed her finger against the Yes option.

With that, she became the fifth member of the King Network.

Part 744: Good Gambling

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Raavul's emergence as a Player did not end up causing much fanfare. Only the other Players present knew it would happen, and they were all close friends with one another, barring the semi-outsider, Paimon. Even though he had spent a few weeks mingling with the others, the Demon Grunt wasn't well-known in Chrona beyond his curious identity as the sole demon in the folded space.

Raavul's body glowed with a faint light for several seconds. After she entered the King Network, Timothy and Ferral took some time to introduce her to how the game worked. As a Psion, the concept of 'video games' was entirely alien to her. She was not like Ferral, who played video games to alleviate his boredom. Raavul was a devoted cultivator whose heart knew only the love of growing stronger through diligent meditation upon her ancestor's insights.

Thus, when Raavul finally opened up her Character sheet for the first time, she had absolutely no idea what anything meant.

* * *

Aspirator Raavul - Psion/Chrona/Volgrim

Level 10 - Aspirator | Mortal

HP 444/444

AP 22/22 | PP 124/124

STR 10 | DEX 12

INT 13 | WIS 14

DEF 12 | RES 12

CHA 13 | LUK 11

CON 9 | END 12

Resistances: Asphyxiation: 100%. Telepathy: 68%. Confusion: 72%. Charm: 32%. Piercing: 18%. Blunt: 14%.

Weaknesses: Magic: 13%. Poison 35%.

Active Skills: Psionic Teacher, Accelerated Projectiles, Atomic Adjustment, (25 Others)

Passive Skills: Player's Body, Player's Mind (Toggle), Psionic Flight, Precision Psionics (Novice), Spatial Psionics (Amateur), Multiclass Lifeform

Talent Slots: 0/1

Prestige: N/A

* * *

Timothy felt himself momentarily blanking out from surprise when he saw Raavul's page. He pulled up Ferral's page, and the comparison was... interesting, to say the least.

* * *

Learner Ferral - Psion/Chrona/Volgrim

Level 7 - Learner | Low Mortal

HP 514/514

AP 14/14 | PP 78/78

STR 11 | DEX 11

INT 10 | WIS 9

DEF 11 | RES 10

CHA 7 | LUK 9

CON 11 | END 13

Resistances: Piercing: 45%. Blunt: 32%. Asphyxiation: 100%. Elemental: 22%. Telepathy: 45%

Weaknesses: Magic: 21%.

Active Skills: Psionic Slam, Psionic Pull, Psionic Telepathy (14 Others)

Passive Skills: Player's Body, Player's Mind (Toggle), Psionic Flight, Multiclass Lifeform

Talent Slots: 0/1

Prestige: N/A

* * *

The biggest thing Timothy noticed was that despite an entire level of Psionic power separating Ferral and his teacher, Raavul's stats were not impressively better than his. To be precise, Raavul's stats in total might have had a point or two more than Ferral, but she was not holistically superior to him in all categories. In fact, Ferral had a much bigger HP pool, a little more STR, and so on. Her biggest gains were in her available Action Points and Psionic Points.

In the King Network, adding even a single primary stat point meant the other entity had taken a step up toward the apex of observable power in the universe. There were only 20 points at most, so in theory the strongest life forms in the universe were a 20 and the weakest were a 1.

Despite this, to only be one or two points stronger than Ferral, Raavul didn't seem that much more impressive than her student.

That was until Timothy noticed the huge gap in skills. She started out with way more skills than Ferral, and on top of that, she even possessed two Psionic Disciplines, namely Precision Psionics and Investigative Psionics.

"Wait, Raavul is already level 10?" Timothy asked doubtfully. "Every other player started at Level 1. Why not her, Umi?"

A speck of light flickered into existence beside Timothy. When the AI spoke, naturally, only he could hear her.

"**The King Network is a living system. It will, on occasion, auto-balance itself. It is designed primarily for low-ranking Sentients to amass strength and climbs the ranks of power. Adding high-ranking Sentients to the King Network is not advised. The results will end in disappointment.**"

Timothy's expression darkened. Raavul ultimately ended up in a similar position to Ferral, with reduced EXP and loot gains. If he really were to invite Blinker, she might start out at Level 50, or perhaps even higher. That would mean she would miss out on the easiest levels to increase and would need to spend ages obtaining meager gains.

Even now, he was strongly reconsidering whether or not he should invite the other Psions to the system after all. Crocodiles were a lot more plentiful in Chrona, and they would get more out of the system too.

There were also people like Rebecca. Was she considered an advanced life form? Would she receive massive debuffs and penalties too? Timothy wasn't sure, and it was the uncertainty that bugged him.

[Teacher Raavul, tell us about the Skills you've acquired.] Ferral said. [Open up your inventory, then write down the words shown under all the skills.]

Raavul, despite being older and wiser than Ferral, was a complete blank slate when it came to understanding anything video game related. She reluctantly became the student, obeying his commands as she whipped out ten different pens and paper pads, rapidly writing down all the details of her character. Most of the skills were self explanatory, but a few were *extremely* interesting.

* * *

Psionic Teacher [Active Skill] [Common] [Growth] [AP X-Cost] [PP X-Cost]

A skill designed for entities who may not be exceptionally strong themselves, but who possess the gift of imparting wisdom and insights upon others. The Player may pay any amount of AP or PP or both to initiate a Lecture. The Player cannot begin regenerating their lost resources until the Lecture is completed.

Lecture: The Player may impart their knowledge of Psionics or other owned Skills and abilities onto other Players. This knowledge is less profound and less powerful than the Player's existing abilities, but as Psionic Teacher improves, so do the quality of the skills it can impart.

Note: The amount of AP and/or PP spent to initiate a Lecture affects the length of the Lecture and the quality of the information taught. Greater costs allow for greater rewards, but also incur greater time costs as well.

Note: The Player who initiates this skill can only pass down 25% of their maximum capability with any skills to other Players. Additionally, this skill is also 25% less effective on non-Players than it already is on Players.

Note: When choosing to level this skill, the Player can choose to improve its skill-level, or improve its rarity. Both can be improved separately, bypassing the usual limit of one skill improvement per level-up.

* * *

Timothy's jaw dropped. When he read the description for Raavul's main active ability, he felt like he was going insane.

Even though her ability seemingly only started as a Common rarity, which was obviously the worst it could be, he could only imagine just how frightening the ability would become as she leveled it up. It was a huge pity she'd lost out on ten initial levels... those would have given Raavul a huge advantage once she caught up to the other Players.

"My god, Raavul!" Timothy exclaimed. "This ability is borderline useless now, but if you pump lots of skill points into it, it's going to blow everyone else's skills out of the water!! You struck gold!"

Raavul did not appear as impressed. Or rather, it would be more accurate to say she didn't understand how the skill worked at all.

[I can roughly grasp the words used in this text, but I feel as if they are hidden behind many abstractions I am unfamiliar with.] Raavul said. [What are 'resources'? How do I lose them? Is losing my resources bad?]

[Teacher, Resources are your Action Points and Psionic Points.] Ferral explained. [They allow you to activate your Skills. They also generally regenerate over time. For example, I regenerate 1% of my lost Psionic Points every minute. According to your skill, if you lecture for one standard time unit, the AP you spend would not begin regenerating until the lecture is complete.]

Raavul nodded, but it was clear she was still lost. She reminded Timothy of an old grandma trying to understand *Mario* or *Pokemon* for the first time.

While Ferral helpfully took his time explaining things to Raavul, Timothy looked at the other information she had written down.

* * *

Precision Psionics (Novice) [Passive Skill] [Class]

Precision Psionics focuses not on overwhelming power, but on extremely fine-tuned control of a Psion's telekinesis and other senses. Psions specializing in this branch of Psionics may eventually reach a point where they can rearrange atoms and nuclei at will. Pairs well with Body Manipulation and Creation Psionics.

This skill does not currently have any effect. It is merely a representation of knowledge the Player has amassed outside of the King Network. If the Player ranks this

skill up, their knowledge of this information will expand proportionately and immediately. If the Player acquires knowledge outside the King Network, this skill can also rank up automatically.

Spatial Psionics (Amateur) [Passive Skill] [Class]

Spatial Psionics focuses on manipulating the Void in various ways. At the lowest level, it can allow one to traverse greater and greater distances with ease or attack their foes through the tearing of space. At the highest levels, a Psion can even construct dimensions within reality, folded spaces capable of holding objects and allowing life to flourish. This branch of Psionics pairs well with Temporal Psionics and Creation Psionics.

This skill does not currently have any effect. It is merely a representation of knowledge the Player has amassed outside of the King Network. If the Player ranks this skill up, their knowledge of this information will expand proportionately and immediately. If the Player acquires knowledge outside the King Network, this skill can also rank up automatically.

* * *

Timothy's expression turned grim. Based on the information presented by these two skills, it seemed Raavul had a big headstart on her students in that she had already acquired two Psionic Specializations, but now she would run into the problem of being too spoiled for choice.

Every single one of her major skills was a contender for being ranked up. That meant the two skill-ups she acquired sometimes through leveling would need to be pondered carefully.

On the other hand, the fact that she could rank up her Specializations just by studying and meditating meant they weren't *completely* essential to level up. But if Raavul truly intended to reach a level someday where she could prevent Chrona from collapsing through her own power, then she would need to advance her specializations even faster than her Teacher skill.

Timothy looked over even more of his skills, then sighed deeply.

Her skills were formidable. Of all the Players currently active, Raavul was the strongest. It was true she was not the most powerful individual in the sense of first and

second place being separated by a vast chasm, but as long as she was diligent with her leveling, she would likely never be surpassed by Ferral, let alone the other Psions.

With all of this in mind, Timothy eventually turned his attention away from Raavul's Character sheet. As a Psion and a Player, Ferral was a better choice to educate her. Timothy had his own concerns.

While Raavul and the others continued to chat, Timothy looked at his inventory. He still had two Rare Skill Lootboxes to open, and an Uncommon Lootbox as well.

When he opened the two Rare boxes, he was presented with many powerful and tempting skills. But ultimately, he decided to stick with his original plan. He chose the skills of Divine Blaze and Flow State which he had previously locked, finally giving himself a proper fighting ability, as well as a way to boost his stats.

Next time I level up, if I get offered skill rank-ups, I'm picking these two skills. I need to see how the skills change. While I don't like using Crocodile Form, it did receive huge improvements each time I leveled it up. And the Octopus Armor is pretty sick too.

The fact it was slimy and it looked really stupid didn't change the fact that it was an easy to use and extremely practical ability. Timothy even started thinking about what would happen if he equipped six 1-handed swords in each tentacle's grasp. Would Divine Blaze light them all on fire? Would the cost increase per sword equipped? What about wielding other weapons?

At the moment, Timothy only had the one common Longsword. But... wasn't forging swords actually relatively easy? He could probably ask his mom to create a whole batch of decent starter weapons. Not to mention his dad had left guns and other such weapons lying around.

Doesn't have to just be swords either. Timothy thought. *Maces, axes, daggers, polearms... there's a lot of variety in what weapons are available, come to think of it.*

Timothy frowned. *I don't actually know how adept at combat these external arms are. They move mostly on autopilot, only taking general mental commands from me. Are they as good at combat as I am? Are they better at combat than me? Do they come with smart AI inside? Can they improve? I should find out when I'm training with Blinker later!*

If they're only as good at shooting guns or swinging swords around as I am, then I'm going to need to do a LOT of training to become even decently competent. On the other hand, if they're way better at combat than me, that would be great, but it would also suck if they didn't get any better as I improved my own skills.

Timothy continued to think and ponder for a while before he turned his attention back to the final Skill Lootbox. The final one was an Uncommon box, so when he opened it, it presented him with three new skills. However, one of them jumped out at him and shook him to his core.

* * *

Skillforging [Active Skill] [Uncommon (Unique)] [Upgrading] [Mana Cost 0] [AP Cost 0] [Cooldown 365 Days]

As a descendant of one capable of shaping reality, you can obtain the ability to reforge your own reality. Once per year, from the Player's temporal frame of reference, the Player may activate this skill to rank up any other skill permanently. Skillforging may not be used to rank up itself. Skillforging may not be used to improve the skills of other Players.

After activation, this skill may not be used again until one Terran year has passed. If the Player forgets to activate this skill after is is ready, no matter how much time passes, once activated the skill still requires a one-year cooldown.

* * *

Timothy's eyes widened. His pupils shrunk. He stared, slack-jawed, at the incredible skill before him. He couldn't even believe what he was seeing.

This was a skill that guaranteed him a permanent way of ranking up all his skills. Even when level-ups started slowing to a trickle, he would be guaranteed the ability to upgrade any of his skills once per year!

Ranking up skills was a big deal. Between the Eye of Yredelemnul obtaining entirely new powers and Crocodile Form's strengths becoming more pronounced while its weaknesses faded away, every rank up made a huge difference in the power of a skill.

The other two options were good in their own ways, but Timothy picked Skillforging without hesitation. Immediately, he started thinking about how he could either improve its rarity or rank it up. Once it was improved, surely the cooldown would reduce, or it

would gain new effects! Spending rank-up points on a skill that ranked up other skills might seem a little absurd, but what if he could get it to the point where it allowed him to rank up a skill every few months, or every month, or god forbid every week or two?!

Wouldn't that be absurd?!

After thinking for a few moments, Timothy decided to activate Skillforging. He triggered it to improve his newly acquired Flow State Skill.

* * *

Flow State (L2) [Passive Skill] [Rare] [Stats] [Toggle]

A Toggle ability that allows the Player to choose from one of three passive bonuses at any given time. These stats can only be swapped if Player is not currently in battle.

Option 1 [Warrior's Physique]: +1.25 to STR and DEF.

Option 2 [Wizard's Mind]: +1.25 to INT and WIS.

Option 3 [Wanderer's Fortitude]: +1.25 to DEX and END.

* * *

Timothy improved Flow State, causing it to improve stats by 1.25, up from 1. This meant it had gained a 25% improvement!

Timothy immediately toggled Flow State, but no matter which option he chose, his stats only increased by 1 point.

Frowning, Timothy decided to question Umi about the matter.

"Umi, why can't my stats rise by more than 1? Isn't this upgrade... a little useless?"

A speck of light flickered into existence before Timothy's eyes.

"**The stat page is not completely accurate in the numbers it depicts. Stats are always rounded down if they have not reached the level of becoming a whole number. A stat of 14 could mean 14.01, or it could mean 14.99. Thus, when you see someone with a stat of a certain numerical level, you should always assume they are 'at least' that strong. This also means reaching a stat value of 20 is essentially impossible. Once you scan enough Entities, you will see increasingly fewer Sentients with stat values reaching the apex of power in the universe.**"

"**Additionally,**" Umi continued, "**True stat values can have tens or even hundreds of digits. The rounded values you see on the stat page should always be taken as approximations.**"

Timothy nodded. "I see. Is there any way for me to see the exact stat values of myself and other entities?"

"**You do not possess this ability at the present time.**" Umi replied blandly.

"Does that mean I could acquire it in the future?" Timothy asked, his eyes lighting up.

"**You do not possess this ability at the present time.**" Umi repeated.

Timothy's face fell. He decided not to continue with his line of questioning. Umi vanished once again, and Timothy smiled in satisfaction.

It's still a 25% improvement. I bet Flow State will become extremely useful in the future. I shouldn't underestimate it. Sigh! I have too many skills that need to be leveled up! A Player's life is never dull.

After he finally acquired his new Skills, Timothy took a good long look at the thirty Tier 1 Lootboxes he had yet to open.

I could level all these boxes up to the next tier, but right now I really could use quantity over quality. Hmm. How about this... I'll turn 9 boxes into three Tier 2 items, and leave the remaining 21 as Tier 1. That should do.

Timothy wasn't just lacking a good quantity of basic *stuff* to work with; he also wanted to test and see what sort of stuff he could get.

As such, Timothy started opening basic Lootboxes one after the other. Each time, a basic item would appear, a skill, or at least materials he could use for crafting.

"Bandages, looks like they can heal an injured state five minutes after being applied. Ten Lightstones to help see in the dark. Oh, a new dagger! It's nothing special, but it's good to have more weapons for my Octopus Form..."

As Timothy pulled out items, he started chatting with Paimon and Marigold, soliciting their opinions.

"What good is half a ton of steel going to do for you?" Marigold asked. "Just pick the poisoned arrows."

"I disagree." Paimon interjected. "The description says the arrows are only effective on weak lifeforms. The steel might be useful for your mother's crafting skills."

Timothy nodded. "I think you're right, Paimon. I'll pick the steel."

When Timothy finished opening all 21 of the Tier 1 Lootboxes, he looked at his gains. One thing he had learned was that 'Tier 1' did not mean 'only Common' items. It seemed to mean 'mostly Common Items, along with weaker Uncommon items'. Unlike the Skill Lootboxes which only gave skills, Tiered Lootboxes primarily gave items, but they did also occasionally offer skills. Some of the stuff he obtained included...

* * *

Tin Compass [Item] [Common] [Utility]

Points north. Always. Even underground, underwater, and in dimensions where north does not conventionally exist. In those cases, it points toward the nearest approximation of north, which is sometimes unsettling. Does not interact with any navigation skills. Cannot be improved further. It simply points north.

Pauper's Fortune [Passive Skill] [Common] [Loot] [No Cost]

Any time the Player would receive an outcome that results in zero gold, zero loot, and zero experience, such as a failed crafting attempt, a missed skill check, or a creature that drops nothing, they instead receive a single copper coin from an indeterminate source. The coin glows with a faint warm light.

Damp Towel [Item] [Common] [Accessory] [Utility]

A standard cotton towel that is perpetually moist. Grants +5% Fire Resistance when draped over the head and reduces the negative effects of arid environments. Will never mold, and can be used as a slight thirst quencher, though the liquid contained within tastes somewhat musky.

Popping Pebble [Active Skill] [Common] [Ranged] [Distraction] [1 MP] [No Cooldown]

Conjures a small, smooth stone in the Player's hand which can be thrown or fired from a suitable projectile launcher. Deals very little damage. Explodes in a flash of light on impact while also generating an audible popping noise. Useful for grabbing the attention of other entities.

Quick Calcs [Passive Skill] [Common] [Utility] [Mental]

Unlocks a virtual calculator in the Player's HUD. The Player can instantly calculate things such as trajectories, vendor discounts, and tax rates without having to stop and think. Especially useful for Biological Inferiors who are extremely slow of mind and need assistance doing basic tasks.

* * *

Obtaining some extra skills was nice, and while nothing was too incredible, and he obtained a lot more basic crafting materials than actual useful devices, he was still quite happy to give himself a decent deal of diversity. Even though it seemed the King Network used Gold Coins for its internal transactions, he thought being able to acquire Copper Coins instead of nothing whatsoever was at least slightly useful.

All that was left now were the three Tier 2 Lootboxes.

Timothy opened them up, and with help from the others, he started choosing his loot.

* * *

Double Jump [Active Skill] [Uncommon] [Movement] [1 MP] [Cooldown 0]

By briefly condensing mana under the soles of their feet, the Player can kick off thin air to perform a second jump mid-flight. Useful for a variety of purposes. With good timing, can be used to save a Player from fall damage. Can only be used once per 'jump instance'.

Sword of Justice [Item] [Common (Growth)] [1 Handed Sword] [Soulbound]

A blade once wielded by an ancient figure of legend. Starts out weak, but whenever the Player kills an enemy designated 'evil', the sword strengthens slightly. If the player ever kills an innocent, the sword shatters, and the player is inflicted with -1 to all stats for 24 hours according to the player's frame of reference.

The blade increases its rarity and power for every 1000 evildoers killed. The sword gains new effects for every 10,000 evildoers killed. The sword will grow stronger when evildoers are killed even if it is not equipped. Unequipping the sword will not prevent it from breaking and inflicting its curse if the Player kills an innocent.

While the Sword of Justice is Soulbound, all sources of great evil will glow an appropriate shade of red in the Player's vision.

Desert Striders [Item] [Uncommon] [Footwear] [Mobility]

Loose-fitting, highly breathable pants favored by deep-dune nomads. Reduces all movement speed penalties associated with walking through difficult terrain such as deep sand, thick mud, or heavy snow by 50%. Zero defensive benefits.

* * *

With these Lootbox rewards, Timothy had obtained additional useful items, and even a skill he thought was neat as heck.

Timothy looked at his MP. He'd already regenerated a small chunk of it in the thirty minutes spent browsing the contents of all these Lootboxes, so he stood up, readied himself, and jumped in the air.

"Hup!"

Timothy leaped upward, and then, through some unknown force of magic, he jumped again! He double-jumped as if stepping on an unseen platform, doubling his original jump height!

...Only for the new ability to make him cry out in alarm as his body itself was unaccustomed to such a maneuver. Timothy flailed his arms and fell forward, slamming onto his face and chest.

"Oof!! Aaa... oww..." Timothy groaned.

It was a lot like trying to jump down a flight of stairs. He simply wasn't prepared to 'fall' that far, and as such, he nearly broke a rib when he landed.

"Oh no, are you okay Timmy?!" Marigold asked, quickly jumping over to his side.

She helped him up, as did Paimon. Timothy grimaced, feeling like an idiot for the umpteenth time that day.

"I'm fine. Just wasn't prepared for the return to the ground. The skill is really cool, but I'm gonna need to practice with it."

At that moment, a haughty voice bellowed. "Darn right you are, young man! You're gonna need lots of training, all of you! That's why I've come to whip your pale butts into shape!"

Timothy and the others jerked their heads to look in the same direction, where they saw Monster Queen Blinker levitating downward, her arms crossed and her back upright,

like a figure of legend descending from on high.

"I hear you guys are planning to go into a Dungeon, eh? Well not BEFORE I take you to the cleaners and make sure you know how to properly fight!"

Ferral cocked his head. [What does cleaning have to do with training our combat skills?]

"It's called that because if you don't perform well, I'll be cleaning your clock!" Blinker shot back.

Ferral looked at Timothy.

[Non-Volgrim figures of speech truly confound me.]

"It's best not to think too deeply about it." Timothy replied consolingly.

Their days of hellish training were about to begin.

Part 745: Training Montage

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Three weeks passed inside Chrona.

When Blinker first arrived to train all the Players, Timothy and the rest had no idea what they were in for. The first thing they discovered was that Blinker had made a special formation that could accelerate the natural healing of their bodies. The second thing they found out was just what that entailed for their training regimen.

Timothy had zero time to do his daily quests. The same was true of Ferral, Marigold, and all the other Players except Fiona. Under Blinker's intensive training, they were subjected to brutal, unending tests of endurance, fast paced combat against foes large and small, and a great deal of focus was put on improving their teamwork.

In the first few days, Blinker simulated underground caverns with kobolds and goblins. After that, she simulated battlefields with orcs and Demon Barons, fireballs exploding nearby, and all sorts of other traumatizing things that left Timothy mentally scarred.

Timothy may have been raised on video games, but he had been shocked the first several dozen times he saw Blinker's hyper-realistic monsters being decapitated, their chests stabbed, their blood spraying, and even their viscera spilling out.

One might have expected Raavul to be the most proficient member of the group when it came to battling, but as it happened, she was almost as green as the rest of them when it came to combat. As a teacher, she spent the majority of her life either as a Learner herself, living in Enclaves, meditating on her Psionic Seed, and other such things. She had never fought in a real life and death battle, so she screwed up many times. If Raavul had one excellent trait, it was that she always maintained a center of calm even in extreme situations. She was not prone to panicking.

Ferral was probably the most consistent performer among the group. Fiona was not planning to enter the dungeons with the team, so Ferral turned out to be their best combat specialist, using his limited grasp on psionics to disorient and debilitate enemies, which allowed Timothy and Marigold to get kills more easily.

Marigold was the most bloodthirsty of the group. As a crocodile, she was a natural predator who did not even blink when it came to blood. She loved ripping things apart and never flinched in the face of danger. It *did* turn out that she had a weakness for 'gross and slimy things', which she quickly thrust onto her boyfriend to take care of.

Timothy found that of all the Players, he was the most well-rounded. He was the weakest member of the group stat-wise, but he'd put a lot of focus on choosing good skills to round out his biggest flaws. Wielding the Sword of Justice, he was able to empower it with flames through the Divine Blaze skill and cut through enemies quite easily. As such, his combat prowess was not shabby in the least.

In the end though, the greatest stand-out figure of them all wasn't a Player in the first place.

Paimon also joined in with the Players in Blinker's month-long training event. In doing so, he revealed himself to be an expert warrior with hundreds of years of combat experience!

Unlike Timothy and the rest, Paimon was not a nerd who spent most of his days indoors. He was a demon, born and raised in demon society. He had grown up fighting for his life, fighting for scraps of food, and fighting for the mere right to live!

Paimon was 40,000 years old, and though he had been stuck as a Demon Grunt his entire life, his fighting style was mature and well-rounded. His abilities were weak, and his estimated stats were only a little higher than Timothy, making him technically the second-weakest member of the group, but in terms of combat knowledge he blew the rest of them out of the water.

Thus, despite being Timothy's Pawn, at the end of the training session, the group unanimously elected him to be their leader!

"It is my honor to accept the position." Paimon said. "I only worry I will let you all down. My strength is lacking."

"It won't be for long!" Blinker said, as she walked over and clapped him on the back. "Come on over to the Workshop, guys. Fiona's been working on a big surprise for all of you!"

Timothy's eyes widened. For four long weeks, he'd been dragging his body to Blinker's Bootcamp every morning at 5 AM, or whatever the Chrona equivalent of morning was,

given it didn't have a sun in the sky, proper. He'd had his body beaten and broken, healed up, then beaten and broken again, never getting to play any video games to relax or even having the time or energy to read a book.

Thus, Timothy hadn't been able to pay attention to his mother's actions, and he had no idea she'd been working on something for him and the rest.

When the group arrived at Jason Hiro's Warehouse, Blinker dramatically thrust the door open to reveal the interior had been completely renovated! No longer did rust coat the walls, nor were the old dusty shelves filled with random buckets of knick-knacks and other assorted crap. Instead, professional-looking sliding shelves, revolving displays, armor and weapon racks, and many other such things now took up the interior of the room.

Fiona leaned back against a countertop, smiling as everyone walked in, with Rebecca standing not too far off to the side. "Timothy, Ferral, Raavul, Marigold, and Paimon! Congrats on surviving Blinker's training. I hear she didn't hold back at all on you greenhorns!"

[Indeed she did not.] Raavul said. [She pushed all of us to our limits. I am eternally grateful for the experience. I learned much about my weaknesses and areas I am in dire need of improvement.]

"I don't feel like a toddler swinging a stick around anymore." Timothy said. "I'm no expert, but I feel like I'm better than an amateur when it comes to swordplay now."

[I have improved the control of my abilities.] Ferral said. [Before Blinker's training, I believed myself to be much stronger than I actually was.]

"I had TONS of fun!" Marigold exclaimed, extending a huge thumbs up. "It was awesome kicking butt for four weeks!"

Paimon simply shrugged. "I don't think I grew much stronger, but I was admittedly a bit rusty at the start. I'm a lot more adept at using my powers again."

Fiona's smile brightened. "Well great! I'm glad to hear the training helped you guys a lot. But that was only the first half of your training. After you leave this workshop, you'll be finishing up the second half next. For now though, I think it's time to show you what I've been working on."

Fiona straightened her posture, then stepped to the side to reveal a steel box with ten shiny circular gadgets inside, each of them roughly the size of Timothy's palm.

"These are T-REX's." Fiona explained. "A core set of armor used during Stormbringer and other major human military campaigns. We had a bunch of them in storage, but they hadn't been used in a hundred years, so their internal circuits had degraded. I used my power to disassemble and rebuild them. Now they're better than ever! I made ten of them, which means there's two for each of you."

Fiona picked up the box and walked over, allowing Timothy and the rest to grab two T-REX's each. It turned out Fiona had labeled all the devices with people's names so everyone would get two sets of armor suited for their constitutions.

"To be honest," Fiona said, "If I hadn't gained Player powers, I couldn't have made these. The energy crisis in Chrona is worsening by the month. Our molecular assemblers don't have nearly enough power to produce anything, so I had to rely on disassembling and reassembling parts from my inventory to make these. Rest assured though, these are the strongest T-REX's I've ever forged!"

Rebecca walked over and lightly rested an arm on Fiona's shoulder. "I helped."

"Yes, yes you did!" Fiona laughed.

Timothy took a look at his two T-REX's. He'd heard of them before, but he'd never seen one in person. Surprisingly, the two T-REX's were different from one another.

* * *

Transforming Replicant Exosuit - Rhino Edition (v3.2) [Item] [Rare] [Torso Armor] [Tech]

A powerful set of nanite-based armor capable of dramatically enhancing the attack and defense of its wielder. This armor was originally invented by Jason Hiro, but was greatly improved by Phoebe Hiro preceding and following the events of the Stormbringer War. It has recently been improved further by the efforts of Fiona Hiro.

This armor grants a high damage reduction bonus to the Player wearing it. It includes a full suite of sensors, communication packages for enabling battlefield chatter with other allied T-REX-wearing Players, and countless miscellaneous systems designed to offer the Player a relatively comfortable wearing experience.

Vacuum-Sealed: This suit has been improved with magical defenses and air filtration systems. It provides immunity to asphyxiation, poisonous gasses, and other external dangers. This effect can be nullified if the suit sustains damage that compromises its outer shell.

Rhino Variant: This heavily armored variant of the T-REX series offers superior defensive protection at the cost of speed and mobility. Never the less, if the Player is able to build up speed, they will execute a [Battle Charge] that can stun or kill any enemies they ram into.

Transforming Replicant Exosuit - Spectre Edition (v3.2) [Item] [Rare] [Torso Armor] [Tech]

A powerful set of nanite-based armor capable of dramatically enhancing the attack and defense of its wielder. This armor was originally invented by Jason Hiro, but was greatly improved by Phoebe Hiro preceding and following the events of the Stormbringer War. It has recently been improved further by the efforts of Fiona Hiro.

This armor grants a high damage reduction bonus to the Player wearing it. It includes a full suite of sensors, communication packages for enabling battlefield chatter with other allied T-REX-wearing Players, and countless miscellaneous systems designed to offer the Player a relatively comfortable wearing experience.

Vacuum-Sealed: This suit has been improved with magical defenses and air filtration systems. It provides immunity to asphyxiation, poisonous gasses, and other external dangers. This effect can be nullified if the suit sustains damage that compromises its outer shell.

Spectre Variant: This stealth and offense-focused armor allows the player to sneak behind enemy lines to execute dangerous foes before they can retaliate, or to scout out enemy positions to prepare an assault. It is also equipped with AI-controlled nano-tendrils that can impale enemies at close range or allow the Player to scale sheer walls.

* * *

Timothy nodded as he read the descriptions for his two T-REX's. The Spectre's tendrils reminded him of the Octopus Form, what with its 'tendrils' that were a lot like the octopus tentacles.

Curious, Timothy donned the Spectre armor. He activated his exosuit while the others activated theirs. Within seconds, a full set of armor had engulfed Timothy from head to toe. The Spectre Exosuit was fantastic, but he quickly realized it was largely incompatible with armor worn elsewhere on his body.

Timothy tried putting on other pieces of armor, but he found that their defensive stats would either overwrite or be overwritten by the T-REX. All their special effects would have the same problem as well. The one exception were small trinkets that could be worn underneath the suit, such as his Earring Radar used to detect movement around him. But, compared to the T-REX's ability to scan for hostiles, the radar wasn't too useful anyway.

Timothy switched to the Rhino suit afterward, and was shocked by how much armor was somehow able to be stored inside a device that fit inside his palm. After donning the exosuit, he rose nearly two feet in height, with insanely bulky armor that would allow him to even fight an average-strength Demon Duke to a standstill.

"I took into consideration everyone's unique circumstances." Fiona explained some time later, after everyone had tried out their new armor. "I gave Timothy a stealth suit and a heavily armored suit so that he would have flexibility in his engagements. I gave Paimon a Hummer exosuit and a Clinician variant because he'll be your designated leader, given his rich battle experience. Unlike the rest of you, Paimon actually knows how to strategize effectively and he's quick when it comes to thinking on his feet."

Fiona turned to address Paimon directly. "The Hummer suit will allow you to fly in the air and get a good aerial view of the battlefield so you can better relay orders to your teammates. From there, you can use your magic to attack at range, or you can use a rifle I'll be personally training you with. However, if you end up underground or in a situation where taking to the air is inadvisable, you can instead use the Clinician suit. I've enhanced its defenses and given it several different medical kits in case anyone gets hurt."

Paimon smiled. "Thank you, miss Hiro. I'm not too familiar with your human technology,+ but I will do my best to master it before we depart. At the very least, I want to get to a point where I'm not making a fool of myself and tripping over my own feet."

Fiona nodded back, then turned to Raavul and Ferral. "You two already have strong and sturdy bodies. I've decided to give you the same suits: A Thundercat and a Clinician. The Thundercat suit is simply a premier baseline T-REX with enhanced offenses and defenses. You might be durable and tough, but these suits will still enhance your

capabilities. As for the Clinician, having more people able to heal serious injures is naturally important."

[I quite enjoyed donning my exosuit.] Ferral said, his tone pleasant. [As Timothy would say, it felt quite 'cool'. Very 'badass'.]

[I won't complain about having extra defensive options, though I don't intend to wear mine often.] Raavul said. [Nevertheless, I thank you for these generous gifts. Once I have reached the 4th or 5th Level of Psionics, these armors will not be of much use, but until then I can feel more at ease with my safety assured.]

"It's better to not need a suit of armor and have it than to need one and not have it." Fiona replied. "If you don't end up using them, that's fine. Just give them to the others."

She turned to the final member of the party.

"Marigold, your situation is a special one. I've decided to give you a Spectre and a Hummer. The reason being that you don't really need offense or defense, but raw utility. If you wear the Hummer, you'll be able to fly, and if you wear the Spectre, you'll be able to sneak around better. Your suits are just designed to shore up your shortcomings. I wouldn't be surprised if they ended up sitting in your inventory doing nothing!"

"Kyargh! Thanks for the cool presents!" Marigold crowed. "I think the Spectre makes me look AWESOME! The black and purple color is a nice touch, and it even covers my tail!"

"Don't forget about the mechanical tendrils on the back." Fiona reminded her. "If you ever end up in a situation where you're surrounded by tough enemies, put on the Spectre. Those tendrils are dangerous and can protect your backside while you rip apart an enemy with your teeth and claws."

"You really know how to speak my language!" Marigold laughed, giving Fiona a thumbs-up. "It feels weird wearing armor, but if my future mother-in-law is gonna put in all this work, I feel obligated to wear it!"

Timothy's face flushed. Hearing Marigold boldly imply marriage was on the horizon was... not something he had expected. He hadn't even given the matter much thought. They'd only been together a couple of months, and he wasn't sure how serious their relationship was.

Fiona cracked a smile when she saw the nervous look on her son's face, but she didn't address Marigold's words directly.

"You've all trained hard. I want you to keep training, but this time I'll have Blinker raise the difficulty several steps while you all wear your new exosuits. If she gives the OK, then in one month, I'll give my approval for you to enter your first Dungeon."

Timothy grinned excitedly. Ferral smiled with his eyes, and Marigold whooped with glee. Paimon shrugged nonchalantly, and Raavul didn't seem emotionally affected one way or the other.

It was a little odd for Fiona to be saying whether or not these people could go into the Dungeon, but as the leader of Chrona, everyone had gotten used to doing things she told them to do. Jason may have been the leader once, but with his death, Fiona, Blinker, and Rebecca had taken up the mantle as Chrona's queens.

Technically, Kar held a lot of sway too, but in terms of political willpower, it was mostly the crocodile faction who listened to his words.

"It's a shame you can't come with us, mom." Timothy said.

"I have too much on my plate, and no time to go out raiding dungeons and whatever other wild antics you guys are going to get into." Fiona said, shaking her head helplessly. "At the very least, I can start looking into my Crafting skill to try and make everyone strong weapons and armor. Timothy, I looked into our reserves and found a decent stockpile of weapons. Why don't you and the rest take a look? I've lined them up over in Row C."

Fiona gestured to a series of shelves that gleamed with the shine of steel. Timothy and the others walked over, where they found all sorts of weapons ranging from knives and sword to guns and blasters. By sweeping the Eye of Yredelemnul over the items, Timothy was able to gather the approximate strength of everything present.

Surprisingly, almost everything was at least Uncommon rarity, and there were even a couple weapons that were ranked as Rare.

"This is an AR-15 from Ancient Earth." Timothy said, hefting one of the bigger, scarier looking black rifles off the shelf. "It might look outdated, but it packs some firepower. Reliable, doesn't jam easily, with enough stopping power to put down enemies on the level of Demon Barons!"

"These Thunder Gauntlets look so cool!!" Marigold screeched. "Wow, they release a burst of thunder when you punch enemies with them! I want this pair!"

Paimon looked at the various weapons on display. "Multiple times, I've run into issues injuring heavily armored enemies. This Rupture Mace looks like it will be ideal for me. A ranged sidearm that burns enemies is a solid backup weapons as well... not too sure how it will work but how hard can pointing and pulling a trigger be?"

Ferral and Raavul made no motion to move toward the weapons. For Raavul, her reasoning was simply that technological weapons were beneath her, and not appropriate for a proper Psion to wield. For Ferral, he was already satisfied with his armor. He preferred to improve his psionic abilities when it came to attacking his foes.

Thus, some time later, Timothy and Marigold had placed several new items into their Inventories, while Paimon, lacking an Inventory, instead wore his weapons on a belt with a large rifle slung over his back. It turned out Fiona had designed it specifically for him, so he couldn't refuse her offer in good conscience. Not using an Inventory seemed a little primitive, but he had a sturdy constitution and could easily handle all his weapons' heft without complaint.

"Alright!" Blinker said, clapping her hands. "One more month of training, and you'll be moving out! Are you excited?!"

"Of course!" Timothy said.

"You know it!" Marigold chuffed.

"Within reason." Paimon said, his voice relaxed.

[I look forward to finally resuming my self-growth.] Paimon said. [Entering a Dungeon will surely prove to be enjoyable.]

[I would rather continue training my students, but I understand this side venture is necessary.] Raavul said, noticeably less enthusiastic than everyone else.

It was clear at a glance that, of the five Players who had obtained the King Network, Raavul was the one least interested in its functionality. She had only agreed to accept its power at Ferral's prompting, but she didn't have much interest in video games, even if they provided her rapid, tangible power growth.

She was a cultivation fanatic! She liked to slowly meditate and grow her strength the 'proper' way. She didn't have much interest in dopamine hits. If Ferral hadn't begged her,

she probably would have turned her down.

Even so, she wasn't treating her new powers flippantly. She intended to master them to the fullest extent possible, understanding that they might be the key to resolving Chrona's future time crisis. She simply wasn't about to break out into a happy song and dance over the matter.

"One more month then." Fiona said, her tone stern. "Then... we'll see what you're made of."

Part 746: Fiona's New System

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

After receiving their T-REX's, Timothy's group immediately launched into another grueling month of boot camp. While Blinker was not a formally trained military member, she did have plenty of battle experience and was suitably blooded, having killed many foes, weak and powerful alike, especially during Stormbringer.

While Blinker didn't have a handbook on how to train recruits, what she did have was her projection powers, and her fairy formations. This meant, unlike the humanity of ancient Earth, she could simulate extremely realistic combat for her recruits, and they could truly learn how to fire and swing their weapons. Additionally, if anyone was badly hurt, they could be healed up in hours underneath the dedicated Medical Formation, which activated the body's natural healing abilities at an absurd level.

On ancient Earth, recruits would often train by reloading their weapons, shooting and throwing grenades at static targets, and other such things, but it would be difficult or at least morally questionable to acquire real living targets to kill. Thus, Blinker's training was a lot more effective in getting Timothy's group used to cutting down hordes of enemies without feeling squeamish.

For the second month of training, Blinker focused on increasing the difficulty of combat each day, little by little. She pitted the group of five against minotaurs, orcs, enemies at the level of Demon Baron, and even did a simulation against Beelzebub as a Duke. In fact, Blinker trained them against several demons she was relatively familiar with, including a simulation fighting a weakened version of Ose, with some of her stats dialed down a little, but still nevertheless a terrifying foe to face while in basic training.

A good portion of the training was focused on making Paimon the commander of the group. It was a little strange making a non-Player the leader, but the more they fought, the more Blinker realized he had a keen strategic mind and was best suited for the role. Timothy was too young and inexperienced, Marigold was too hot-headed, Ferral was probably the best runner-up, and Raavul was leery of making 'gut decisions'. She preferred to only make moves based on known intel, and wasn't good at weighing and taking risks.

Thus, Paimon ended up being the leader. Blinker wanted to come along, but she was not a Player, and neither was she an entity summoned by a Player, like Paimon was, so she simply couldn't. Timothy had already debated whether he should make her a Player, but after seeing the nerfs the system gave to Raavul, he decided that even if he had another Player slot available, it wouldn't be a good idea.

Thus, four weeks passed by. Timothy and the rest didn't have time to do their daily quests, but surprisingly, the extensive combat training actually increased a few people's stats by a few points.

Timothy gained 2 STR and 2 END, as well as 2 DEX.

Marigold gained 1 STR, 2 END, and 1 DEF.

Ferral gained 1 DEF and 2 RES.

Raavul gained nothing, and neither did Paimon.

Timothy was the weakest, so Blinker's training benefited him the most. Marigold, as the party's tank, took the most abuse, so she gained quite a bit herself. Ferral was the secondary tank, so he also improved his defenses a little, but the other two were either too powerful or couldn't benefit from the King Network's reward functions.

Thus, in the end, the teamwork of the group improved further beyond their starting point, and with Blinker's help, they felt ready for the journey ahead.

"I can't wait to start!" Marigold crowed. "I'm so tired of fighting fake weaklings and not getting any cool items or EXP!"

"I wouldn't call Ose a weakling..." Timothy said with a shudder. He was still slightly traumatized from the simulation a few days earlier against her.

"You guys can enter the Dungeon whenever you want, but I recommend resting for a couple of days first to condition your minds and bodies back to their optimal state." Blinker suggested. "A few days off will do wonders to get you in a better head-space. Also, Timothy, your mother wanted to see you. She told me to wait until your training was done. She said she had a question for you."

Timothy nodded. "I need to take a shower first, but I'll go and see her in a bit."

Everyone said their goodbyes, and Timothy trudged home, his body sore and aching from the training. He took a shower and ate some food that Paimon had whipped up now that they shared a house, then Timothy headed over to meet his mom at the Spynet.

When Timothy arrived, the door was unlocked. It had already been a couple of months since his 'peeping' incident, and given he had a girlfriend now and had been a good boy, Fiona had eventually stopped locking him out and started showing some trust toward him again.

When Timothy entered the Spynet and looked around, he frowned. It had only been two months since he last had time to come over, but already three dozen more monitors had burned out. Now, less than a third of the Spynet's monitors were spying on the various Sentients of the Milky Way, and all the monitors that had once focused on the Volgrim were completely blank.

There were still plenty of monitors pointed at the humans on Sharmur as it hadn't yet been absorbed into the Cube, and there were monitors that displayed some parts of various monster and demon worlds, but Fiona no longer had even a scrap of intel regarding what the Volgrim were up to.

Timothy looked at the monitors for a moment, then he knocked loudly on the door to catch his mother's attention.

"Mom! You in here?"

A moment later, Fiona popped out from behind a pile of monitors laying on the floor in a darker part of the room.

"Oh, Timothy, there you are. Good timing."

She stepped out of the pile of monitors, then stretched while gritting her teeth. Her back audibly popped, and she cracked her neck afterward. It seemed her body was becoming less phantasmal and more corporeal as time went on, though she would never 'truly' become a genuine human like Phoebe was.

Fiona walked over to a desk, then swiped a piece of paper and handed it to her son.

"What's this?" Timothy asked as he looked down at the paper.

"I hit level 10 several weeks ago while you were in training. I'm level 13 now." Fiona said. "I obtained these options for my Level 10 System unlock, but I'm not sure what to choose..."

Timothy's eyes widened. He quickly looked at the paper.

* * *

[Pawn Summoning]

The Player may summon a Pawn from across time and space to accompany them on their journey. The Pawn is random and cannot be chosen, but unwanted pawns can be discarded and re-summoned every set period of time. The period of time can be influenced by many factors. Pawns are NPCs that can either be mindless robotic companions or full-fledged characters with their own journeys and desires.

[Real Time Strategy Mode]

The Player obtains the ability to switch their perspective to an omniscient top-down perspective of the area they currently reside upon. When in RTS Mode, the player can execute broad management strategies for the 'units' they control as well as the Buildings inside their region. The Player can only alter or command forces under their control and will be unable to alter the forces of enemy or allied factions.

[Automated Factory]

Crafting System required to access this sub-system.

The Player gains access to a new system which allows them to place down automated crafting devices which can feed into one another to make weapons, armor, devices, and just about anything else on demand. This system can quickly convert raw materials into functional tools, provided the Player has taken the time to construct their automated factory. This system requires a lot of time and resource investment in order to produce results, but those results can turn out far greater than the base Crafting system by itself.

* * *

Timothy read the paper his mother gave him and his heart nearly stopped.

Seeing the look on her son's face, Fiona nodded. "That's about the reaction I expected. I'm at a loss of what to choose. I know doubling up on these systems is probably a bad idea, but Paimon has been a great help to you and your friends, so I was thinking being able to summon an assistant, or maybe an army of assistants would be useful."

"But," Fiona continued, "I then thought that this 'RTS' mode sounded like it could be exceptionally useful too. I thought you might know better than me."

"It's good." Timothy said slowly, feeling a great sense of disbelief at his mother's incredible options. "It's really good. It's like an Empire Building system, basically. It's perfect for you. It's exactly what you're good at."

"Right, but that Automated Factory sounds great as well..." Fiona said, her tone hesitant. "I worry we don't have enough raw materials on hand to make it useful. What's most important is that nobody else has Crafting but me, so if I don't pick it, someone else will need to choose the Crafting system to get access to Automation. I feel like it's tailor-made for my needs."

Timothy massaged his face furiously. "Gah! If I were to pick, I'd pick the RTS Mode in a heartbeat. But you're right, this Automation option sounds awesome. I definitely don't think you should pick Pawn Summoning, mom. Maybe I can level my Pawn Summoning up and summon you some assistants. Doubling down on my System is a bad idea."

It didn't take long before the two of them came to a decision.

"I'll choose Automated Factory then." Fiona said. "I've barely touched the Crafting System except a little fiddling with it here and there. It seems useful, but I've been too busy using my basic abilities and leveling up to bother with it. Maybe if I invest in this Factory option, I'll have to bring myself use the Crafting skill a lot more."

With that, Fiona made her choice. There was little fanfare, and certainly nothing Timothy could see, but his mother's eyes lit up after a few moments.

"Oh! Ohh! How intriguing!" Fiona exclaimed. "Wow, this is more interesting than I thought! Ohh!"

"What is it?" Timothy asked. "Did something happen??"

Unfortunately, his mother didn't immediately elaborate. She kept staring off into space, or rather, her invisible inventory, oohing and ahhing at something Timothy couldn't see.

Suddenly, Timothy realized this must be how ridiculous he looked when he first showed off the power of the King Network. He must have looked like a complete idiot, staring at absolutely nothing while everyone else waited. It was his just desserts that he had to suffer and wait for his mom to snap out of her daze. What went around came back around...

Five long, excruciating minutes passed. It almost seemed as if Fiona had completely forgotten her son was there, but eventually she snapped out of her daze, blinked her eyes, then turned to Timothy with a giddy expression.

"The King Network just gave me several items, and they're all Soulbound Legendaries!"

"What? Legendary items?!" Timothy exclaimed. "I wanna see, mom!"

"I can't exactly show them to you. I'm not allowed to trade them to other players. I have to summon them with my new ability 'Amateur Factory Worker'." Fiona explained. "Basically, using these items, I can pick up and move objects and even buildings for... basically no cost!"

Timothy squinted. "I don't get it. You can already pick stuff up and move it around."

"No, silly. Didn't you hear what I said?" Fiona quipped. "I said items AND buildings! BUILDINGS, Timothy! I can move buildings!"

Timothy's eyes widened. "Wait, seriously? How does that even work?"

"I don't know! Let's go test it out." Fiona said.

And so they did. The mother and son went outside and walked over to one of the ordinary residences that wasn't currently being used. Fiona poked the air with her finger, and all of a sudden, a strange gun that looked like a prop from a 1960's sci-fi movie appeared in her hand. It was yellow with blue rings around what Timothy assumed was the 'barrel' of the gun, except it had some sort of a Tesla-style orb poking out of the end. It looked like it was designed to shoot ray beams or lasers or something.

Frankly, Timothy thought it looked silly and cartoonish.

Fiona held the small gun in one hand. Then, she pointed it at the building.

A few seconds later, she frowned and pulled it away. "That's weird. I can't activate the tool. It says there are 7,044 life forms inside the structure, preventing it from being moved."

"Seven thousand??" Timothy asked in bewilderment.

"Yes. Umi, nobody lives inside the building. Why would it give me that warning?" Fiona asked.

Once again, Fiona spoke to someone Timothy couldn't hear, and while he knew it was obviously Umi, he once again realized how silly it looked when a Player seemingly talked to the air itself. He made a silent vow not to do that when non-Players were present.

"Oh." Fiona said after a moment. She scratched her head. "It seems, um, there are bugs inside the building. Lots of them. The tool can't move a structure that has any lifeforms inside of it."

"That's an odd restriction." Timothy muttered.

"Well, there's another restriction too, which is that the structure I want to move has to have been 'mostly' constructed by me personally, or by my powers. So I have to have been responsible for at least 51% of the building process. And, well, it was your father who made all the buildings in Chrona, so I can't actually use the tool on them."

"That's unfortunate." Timothy said, shrugging his shoulders. "Maybe it'll be useful in the future?"

"Definitely!" Fiona chirped. "Because the restriction on buildings doesn't apply to smaller objects. Check this out!"

She pointed at a shovel leaning against a wall. Then she aimed the fake-toy-looking gun at the shovel and pulled the trigger. A split second later, the shovel abruptly turned into a speck of light, then flew toward Fiona's body with a blur of movement before disappearing right before it was about to strike her.

"Huh?!" Timothy guffawed. "The heck was that?"

"I can move items directly into my inventory with this gun." Fiona said smugly. "And I can place them down remotely too, even controlling the exact positioning."

"But... all you need to do is touch an item to add it to your inventory." Timothy said hesitantly. "That gun doesn't seem all too useful."

"Usefulness is in the eye of the beholder. I can instantly take a monitor off the ceiling now, then put it on the ground, repair it, and stick it back on the ceiling where it originally was." Fiona explained. "And that's just one thing this gun will let me do now! Furthermore, this isn't even the only new tool I acquired."

With a wave of her hand, Fiona made the gun vanish with a flash of light. Then, a new device appeared in her palm. It looked like an equally cartoony and deeply unserious device, colored gray with a red antenna doohickey sticking up out of the top right corner. It had some buttons on the front, and a black screen with green text on it. When Timothy looked at the green text, it looked like random letters and numbers, completely gibberish placeholder text.

"With THIS device, I can scan any inanimate object and see a listing of its faults, its wear and tear status, and any structural issues. Then if I spend resources, I can automatically repair the object back to working order using a third device. This is really going to speed up my constant repair work around Chrona!"

Timothy was completely bewildered. "I mean, that one sounds a lot more useful, but why does it look so... silly? It's made of cheap plastic."

"No idea." Fiona said, shrugging the question off. "All I care about is that it works. I also have a Constructor and Recycler tool. They work a lot like my active skills, except they retrieve 100% of the materials used to build things, minus any degraded or damaged components. So I can deconstruct buildings and large objects, then use their parts to rebuild the same objects or different ones."

Timothy raised an eyebrow. Suddenly, his mom's newest upgrade didn't sound so pitiful anymore. "It sounds like you've acquired all the tools you need to completely tear down and rebuild Chrona from scratch..."

"That's exactly it!" Fiona exclaimed. She beamed a bright smile at her son. "I'm really starting to like these powers, Timothy. We might have a real shot at repairing Chrona's foundations. When you enter the Dungeon, I want you to be safe, but also try to see if you can acquire lots of raw materials for me. That half-ton of steel, for example. The more stuff like that you can get me, the better."

"Sure, mom. I can do that." Timothy agreed wearily. "I'm glad your new ability is exactly what you needed. I'm gonna go home and get some sleep. I'm still pretty beat from Aunt Blinker's training."

"Are you hurt?" Fiona asked, as a hint of concern played on her face. "Need me to use my Mother's Intuition skill to heal you?"

"Cough cough!! I'm fine!" Timothy said awkwardly. "I'm gonna go now. Bye mom!"

Even though he was a little embarrassed, Timothy didn't neglect to give his mother a hug and a kiss goodbye. Afterward, he headed home and plopped down face-first on his bed to sleep.

"Two more days." Timothy muttered. "Two more days and we can finally do our first dungeon raid."

He smushed his face into his pillow and grinned like an idiot.

"I'm so excited! I can't wait!"

Part 747: Entering the Dungeon

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Two more days passed inside Chrona. By now, nearly two months had come and gone since Timothy first acquired the King Network and passed it on to his friends.

With two days of relaxation so everyone could unwind, the group of five had returned their minds to a state of semi-calm. Under the surface, excitement was boiling, though this was mainly the case for Timothy, Ferral, and Marigold. Paimon and Raavul were less interested in exploring the dungeon, with the former only doing so at his master's command, and the latter doing so out of begrudging obligation, but they were not going to hold back due to a simple lack of enthusiasm. Too much was on the line.

After readying themselves and donning their T-REX armors, the group of five stood in an empty flower-field outside the eastern part of the city, with Rebecca, Blinker, Kar, and Fiona standing not too far away.

"Hurgh. Bring me back some meat if you can." Kar said. "I'd like to taste the flavor of these Dungeon creatures."

"Stay safe." Fiona said. "That's an order. Timothy, don't you dare be reckless inside there. I don't know what you'll encounter, but treat your life as if survival is paramount!"

Blinker looked more relaxed than anyone else. "If you guys knew the hell I'd put these maggots through, you wouldn't be worried. They're better trained than Jason was during Stormbringer! I whipped their butts into shape."

"It's a shame none of us can come with you." Rebecca added. "I hope the enemies you face are within your capabilities to dispatch."

"Relax!" Marigold laughed. "Kyargh! We've got ME here, and I'm a badass now! Timothy's pretty strong too! You should see his sword skills! He's not just swinging it around like a lunkhead anymore!"

[I will ensure this group returns fully intact.] Raavul vowed. [You have my word.]

Everyone said goodbye, and Timothy made sure to give his mother, his aunts, and even his crocodile uncle a big hug before he left. Not even Rebecca was excluded, as Timothy saw her as his surrogate aunt.

"I'm wary of the Dungeon, but far from afraid." Timothy said. "We can do this! See you later, everyone! We'll return soon!"

With that, Timothy's group turned to look at Ferral.

[I only have the ability to 'Activate Dungeon.'] Ferral warned. [I do not know what will happen next. For all we know, we might be thrown into a random area and separated. Be prepared for anything.]

Everyone nodded. They waited with bated breath as Ferral activated his Enter Dungeon command.

Then... a portal opened up in front of them. It looked like a swirling blue oval of energy. Everyone blinked in unison. They didn't expect this.

Raavul held up her hand. [I will enter first. I am the most powerful.]

With that, she levitated forward, and vanished into the portal.

Ten long seconds passed. Just when Ferral was about to step through, Raavul slipped back outside the portal. There was an odd expression on her face.

[The situation... is not dangerous. You may all enter.]

She didn't explain anything, which only left the others wondering what the heck she had just seen. Unable to bear their curiosity, they quickly entered the portal after her, with Blinker and the others excluded. As they were not Players or Pawns, they could not enter.

"I wonder what's inside..." Blinker muttered.

"I might check it out later." Fiona replied. "We'll see."

Even after the group of five entered, the portal continued to levitate silently in the air, making those who gazed upon it wonder if they, too, could enter...

* * *

Timothy arrived inside what he immediately identified as a grand library. It was filled with rows and rows of books, with shelves rising fifty feet up to the ceiling, way beyond what anyone could easily reach. In addition to him, the other four were also there.

"A library." Ferral said, his senses on high alert. "Not what I was expecting."

Just as the group was wondering what sort of dungeon they had entered. An astoundingly tall, frighteningly slender figure suddenly stepped out of one of the library

aisles in front of them. Everyone's hearts jumped as they looked at the quadruped figure before them. It looked like an unbelievably emaciated centaur, except its body was made of transparent blue 'goop' vaguely resembling Jello. When their eyes moved higher, they saw that 45 feet up, the creature had a long neck with a tiny head and two beady eyes.

It wasn't a scary looking creature, but it was the most alien thing any of them had ever seen in their lives. Each of its four ground-based limbs were as slender as a kitchen sink pipe, with hooves like on a bull, and even its main body was only as thick as a telephone pole. The creature had two long arms that looked like they could reach way above its head, with one thumb and two fingers each.

When the giant skinny creature stepped out of the aisle, its eyes lowered to look at them.

"Or? Mashu? Sheldo nowa ko."

The creature spoke extremely slowly. Each syllable was evenly pronounced, and its tone was completely emotionless.

"I... what's it saying?" Marigold asked, bewildered. "Is it a boy or a girl? I can't tell..."

The others seemed lost too, but Timothy wasn't. Since he had chosen Universal Translator, he realized he could perfectly understand the creature.

"Oh? Who are you? It's been a while since Po had guests." The creature said.

Timothy blinked. He opened his mouth to speak, but the words that came out of his mouth were complete mumbo-jumbo to the rest of his group. Without even meaning to, he perfectly replicated the creature's language.

"I'm sorry. We didn't mean to disturb you. I am Timothy, and these are my friends."

"Ah. Timothy." The creature said, bobbing his head up and down. "Po I am. Po organizes the Story Hall. You are a well-mannered creature. Po likes you."

After a short pause, Po lifted his head and stood back at his full height.

"Po understands now. You are the new Administrator. Welcome to the Story Hall. What story do you intend to experience today?"

The others looked at Timothy. They realized immediately that he could speak the creature's language, with only Raavul not knowing about his Universal Translator skill.

Ferral silently filled her in, and nobody interrupted Timothy while he conversed with the creature.

"I thought I was coming here to run through a Dungeon..." Timothy said hesitantly. "Why are we in a library?"

"Dungeon. Oh yes. Po knows of Dungeon. This is another word for story. We have many story-dungeons." Po said. "This is Timothy's first time experiencing story?"

Timothy nodded slowly. "Yes. It's my first time."

"How wonderful." Po said, his tone not particularly one of excitement. "Come with Po. Po will show you how to enjoy story."

The large creature slowly turned around, then began walking forward. Despite Po's immense size, he made no noise at all while he walked, as if he were not a real creature but a ghost. The silence was eerie...

The group walked behind Po, and Timothy quickly caught them up on what Po was saying. Seeing as they weren't actually in a Dungeon yet, everyone relaxed a little. It turned out they would be able to exert some control over what sort of Dungeon they would enter, and not just randomly pop into an unknown scenario.

Po strode behind a giant desk with a top that rose twenty-five feet above the head of Timothy and the rest. After a long moment of silence, Po craned its neck to look over the front of the desk at the people below.

"Timothy. Po has gathered many excellent stories for you to enjoy. Since you are not adept in story traversal, perhaps Po may make a suggestion for which story to enter?"

Timothy slowly nodded. "That would probably be for the best, Po. What do you suggest?"

He had realized by now that Po was a lot like Giuseppe. He was one of the King Network's NPCs. Most likely, there were going to be more that Timothy would inevitably meet.

Since that was the case, it seemed Po was not his enemy. He seemed like a friendly..... *creature*.

"Po, what species are you?" Timothy asked.

Po blinked slowly. He looked at Timothy with a blank face.

"Po is Po." Po said. "There is only one Po."

Timothy was surprised. "You're the only member of your species? The only one??"

"Po is Po." Po repeated.

Timothy needed a moment to digest that information. "I see. Well, you're certainly an interesting individual, Po."

"Po appreciates the compliment." Po said. "Po also thinks you are an interesting individual. Your body should be incapable of properly replicating Po's language, but you are able to do so anyway. As expected of the talented Administrator."

Po raised his head. There was a rustling noise on the table. Eventually, Po lifted a book off the table, then, unexpectedly, Po lightly tossed the book up in the air. Timothy and the others jumped in fright as the gigantic book suddenly flew over the table and fell toward them, its size drastically enlarging as it was about to crush them!

But, just before the book made impact, it halted in midair, then pulled backward, levitated downward, and rested on the ground, its cover visible before all of them.

"A book??" Marigold asked. "What's up with that?"

The book did not have any words on it. Instead, it looked like the entire cover was an illustrious painting, one that was so lifelike and real that if it started moving, everyone would think they were looking at another world entirely.

The image on the cover was of a forest in the middle of the day, as if looking at the trees from a grassland, except that beyond the trees there were shadows engulfing the inner forest, with tiny pairs of white eyes peeping out of the inner gloom.

Such a forest appeared ominous and foreboding. The book gave everyone who looked at it the heebie-jeebies.

"What think?" Po asked curiously. "A suitable first story? Po assures you, this story is not too difficult. A good introduction to stories for the uninitiated."

Timothy hesitated. The shadowy forest looked irksome, but he couldn't really get a clue about what they would be facing just from the cover...

"Po, what will we find if we read the story?" Timothy asked.

Po blinked his eyes. "Po does not spoil stories. Po thinks stories must be enjoyed without any outside context. Po would never ruin your fun by spoiling you."

"Oh. Uh. Thanks..." Timothy said with a grimace.

A minute passed as everyone observed the book.

"Looks exciting. Let's give it a try!" Marigold crowed, giving her boyfriend a big thumbs-up. "How scary could trees be?"

Timothy sighed. "Alright, we'll give this story a shot. What is it called?"

Po's face remained expressionless. "All stories have titles. The title will be revealed when you experience it. Open the book to begin."

Timothy nodded. Without further ado, he stepped forward, grabbed the edge of the book, and pulled it open.

A powerful suction force swept outward. With a flash of light, the five party members vanished, and they entered the world of the book.

Timothy and the others fell down, down, down inside a pitch-black void.

The Party members eventually slowed to a stop and landed on their feet inside the void. They could easily see one another, but everything else around them was pitch-black.

After they landed, giant words appeared in the air before all of them.

* * *

DARK FOREST DUNGEON

A forest filled with extremely powerful life forms. These life forms are vicious and bloodthirsty. Crossing them will likely mean death. In order to pass through, the party must move stealthily. If the Party inadvertently catches the attention of a powerful life-form, the party must quickly defeat their adversary and hide, lest more enemies are drawn to the scene.

Difficulty: Very Easy

Dungeon Level: 1

Dungeon Objectives: The Party must traverse the Dark Forest successfully. The Party will start at the southern edge of the Dark Forest. The Party must reach the northern edge before the time limit expires.

Time Limit: 1 Week.

Rewards if successful: Level 1 Dungeon Rewards x5. Bonus rewards obtainable if hidden criteria are met.

Penalty if failed: All party members +3 levels. Skip all level-up rewards. A Dungeon Break event will occur.

* * *

The team grimaced when they saw the penalty. The fact they would all gain three levels without gaining any benefits if they failed the dungeon was a huge demerit, and the Dungeon Break sounded even scarier. On the other hand, the rewards didn't seem all too enticing. Level 1 Dungeons were likely the easiest dungeons possible, so how good could their rewards be?

"This dungeon seems difficult..." Marigold said hesitantly. "It says 'very easy' but how easy can it be when the forest has 'extremely powerful lifeforms' inside it?"

The others were quiet for a moment. Before anyone could speak, a window popped up in front of all of them.

* * *

Party status

Paimon (Leader): Not Ready

Timothy: Not Ready

Marigold: Not Ready

Ferral: Not Ready

Raavul: Not Ready

Ready up? [Yes/No]

The Dungeon will begin once all Party members have readied up.

* * *

Timothy breathed a sigh of relief. "Look like we have time to think before we enter."

"Then we should strategize." Paimon said. "Read the Dungeon description carefully. The key to victory is stealth. We don't have to fight any enemies. In fact, since these enemies are said to be so strong, combat is likely a terrible idea."

[What about flying over the forest?] Raavul inquired. [Ferral and I can both fly. We can easily bring the rest of you along, and that's without mentioning the Hummer exosuits.]

[That might not be advisable.] Ferral retorted. [What if the monsters in the forest see us flying overhead? We would appear quite conspicuous. Flying over the treetops could be the antithesis of stealth.]

"Ferral's right." Timothy added. "But also, read the description carefully. Stealth is essential, and it doesn't say all of us have to reach the end. Maybe me and Marigold could wear our stealth exosuits and sneak in by ourselves."

"That's too dangerous." Paimon said, making a chopping motion with his hand to express disapproval. "That suit is great at stealth, but these enemies could be observant enough to spot you. If you were attacked, the rest of us wouldn't be there to fight alongside you. You might die."

[Not to mention that simply because the description does *not* say we *all* have to make it to the objective, that does not mean only one or two of us can.] Raavul pointed out. [It may just be that we all must arrive there together. The description does not say one way or another. Best to err on the side of caution.]

Marigold didn't have much to say. She wasn't the brightest member of the bunch, so she decided to let the smart people talk things out.

After debating for a while, the other four came to a consensus.

"Alright, so we'll all go in, T-REX's equipped." Paimon said. "Even the basic suits can increase our speed and muffle our footsteps. Furthermore, we can speak to each other without outside observers hearing our voices. We could probably have Raavul and Ferral set up a telepathic communication relay if that weren't possible, but it's too troublesome, so let's rely on the suits."

"Unfortunately, Paimon, your two exosuits are way too flashy." Timothy said. "The Hummer emits a lot of heat and light from its grav-wings. The Clinician is colored bright-white. It's really going to stand out in the darkness..."

He looked at Raavul and Ferral next. "Both of you also have Clinicians, but the Thundercats are blue and red. They'll blend in a *little* better with the underbrush."

Then he looked at Marigold. "You've got a Spectre and a Hummer. Just use the Spectre and you'll be good. Your scales are bright yellow, so you need to be even more incognito than the rest of us."

"Yeah? Well you have pale white ghostly skin!" Marigold teased, sticking her tongue out. "Maybe you should get some sunlight and a tan, eh, Timmy?"

Timothy smirked. "Chrona doesn't *have* a sun. But yeah, point taken. That's why I'm wearing a stealth suit too."

After a bit of deliberation, Paimon shook his head. "I'll just have to use my Clinician. Bright white is not a great color option, but it's the stealthiest option at hand. After this mission, we should make sure everyone has a Spectre for the sake of future operations. At the very least, we should recolor the Clinicians to be more stealthy."

"Yeah, you said it." Timothy nodded.

Before long, everyone donned their exosuits and turned to the giant screen floating in the air. One by one, they pressed the Ready button, and eventually, the black void dissolved around them.

The group found themselves at the same spot depicted on the cover of Po's book. Before them was a forest that stretched on seemingly for miles to the left and right of their starting position. But when they turned around to look backward, they found there was a wall of impassable mist behind them as well. Paimon tried to enter it, but the mist was as solid as steel!

"It's a world boundary." Timothy said. "A fake wall. We can only go forward, into the forest."

He looked at his Quest screen, where it showed the Dungeon quest's time remaining counter ticking down from *6:23:59:47*.

Timothy looked at the HUD inside his helmet. Unfortunately, the compass wasn't working. It seemed the false world didn't have an equivalent to a magnetic north pole like on most worlds. The compass spun around in slow circles, unable to lock onto anything. Ultimately, Timothy had everyone face the forest, then lock that direction as 'north' so they wouldn't get lost or accidentally turned around once they entered.

"Time's a-wasting, guys! Kyargh! Let's go already!" Marigold eventually said.

"Don't rush." Timothy urged. "Marigold, you and I have the only stealth suits. We'll go in first. *Sneaky*. Got it?"

"Yeah, yeah. I got it. I'm not *stupid*, you know." Marigold groaned. "Come on, we're on the clock now."

Timothy nodded. He and Marigold quickly moved forward. They entered the forest first, and Timothy glanced at his helmet's tracking radar. It always displayed red dots indicating the position of his allies who were wearing exosuits, but as he and Marigold entered the forest, the other three party members suddenly had their dots disappear.

"Wait, pause." Timothy said to Marigold quietly. "I didn't expect this."

Marigold looked at him with a frown, though her expression wasn't visible underneath her armor.

Timothy carefully stepped out of the forest. Once he'd exited its confines, the other three showed up as red dots again, but Marigold vanished.

"There's a boundary of some kind separating the forest from the exterior." Timothy concluded. "Everyone, just come in with us. We can't afford to get separated."

Raavul nodded. "Yes, we will join you."

She, Ferral, and Paimon all stole into the forest. Paimon's white armor did indeed stick out in the darkness a little, but as soon as they traveled into the forest, they realized the forest itself was deeply, unnaturally dark and gloomy. The tree canopy didn't seem to be terribly thick, yet somehow, the only light that entered the forest came from the path behind them. By the time they'd traveled just 100 meters inside, they found themselves in utter darkness.

By that point, even the bright white color of Paimon's Clinician suit was practically invisible. It wasn't as if their suits needed running lights. They simply switched to night vision which caused the tiny bits of light that *did* filter down through the tree canopy to light up their surroundings to a barely acceptable level.

Even so, Timothy really had to squint to see ahead of himself. He intended to move quickly and stealthily, but he kept stepping on twigs and leaves, making him conspicuously louder than he intended. He wanted to move silently, but he couldn't see the ground in front of him!

"Shit. This is harder than I expected." Timothy muttered.

He looked at the clock on the quest page.

6:23:51:13

"Let's just... take it slow, everyone." Timothy said quietly. "No sense rushing."

The forest was deathly silent. The further they traveled into the vegetation, the more eerie and alien the environment felt.

In addition to all the trees, the vegetation itself was annoyingly dense. There were plants and small trees and bushes everywhere, often concealing two or even three feet of the forest floor.

Eventually, Timothy slowed to a stop. He gestured for the others to come over.

"We should try hopping from tree to tree." Timothy said. "The trees are somewhat far apart, but it should be doable."

"That's going to make even more noise." Paimon warned with a whisper. "It might work for you and Marigold since your Spectres have those handy climbing tendrils, but I don't have such a luxury. Maybe we should try the levitation strategy."

The group had already discussed a few options prior to readying up, and this strategy was one of them.

[We can levitate the three of you...] Raavul said hesitantly. [But I am only a 3rd Level Psion, and Ferral is a 2nd Level Psion. If we have to focus on levitating you, we will not have energy to spare on observing our surroundings.]

As low level Psions, they had powers roughly equivalent to Demon Barons, which was fairly formidable. The problem was, their multi-tasking abilities were far beneath those of more powerful Psions, especially the ones who had ascended to the level of Cosmic. This was another reason why a telepathic link sustained by Ferral and Raavul to the others was a worse idea than relying on the T-REX's; because if they established such a link, it would weaken their other abilities.

"Don't worry. You and Ferral just focus on getting us to the other end of the forest. Me, Marigold, and Paimon will keep a lookout. Me on the front, Marigold on the back, and Paimon on the sides."

Paimon nodded. "We're making way too much noise wading through the underbrush, and our speed is terrible. We'll be even louder if we hop from tree to tree. I think levitation is our best bet."

"We don't know how far we have to travel to reach the other side of the forest." Marigold chimed in. "Maybe if we don't speed up, we'll miss the deadline and fail the Dungeon."

The two Psions looked conflicted, but after thinking things over, they eventually agreed.

[Alright. I'll fly on the left, and Ferral on the right.] Raavul said. [We'll levitate the three of you between us. Timothy at the front, Paimon in the middle, and Marigold in the back.]

"Sounds good to me." Marigold readily agreed.

"It's our best shot." Timothy added.

Like this, they assumed the new formation, and began flying forward, with Timothy and Marigold 'laying' flat in the air while Paimon 'stood' on nothing, giving himself a better vantage point. Timothy watched the entire area up ahead, occasionally switching between night vision and thermals to see if he could spot anything moving.

Paimon swiveled his head from side to side, looking to the left and right. He put his full focus on their mission.

As for Marigold... she lazily looked around behind the group, quickly growing bored.

It's really relaxing, levitating like this. Really... relaxing... Marigold thought to herself. Her eyes started to droop a little. *So soothing...*

Unseen by the group, a single creature hid itself up in the treetop branches. Its beady yellow eyes peered down at them as it stealthily pursued them from behind.

Timothy and his friends were not alone.

Part 748: The Dark Forest

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Time passed quickly inside the Dark Forest Dungeon. Before long, three hours had come and gone. The Dungeon stopped looking like an endless sea of trees and shrubbery. At some point, the party of five started encountering more diverse terrain. They saw a pitch black pool of water in the distance, where there was a notable void of trees around it. They had to take a detour to get around it, and they slowed their pace a little, looking at the water with fear in their eyes.

The pool had creatures near it! Faint torches were held aloft by powerful warriors armed with primitive-looking sharpened spears. For the first time, the party spotted life lurking at the edge of the small lake, each individual looking around warily. A few creatures carefully scooped water out of the lake with that looked like five gallon buckets. They looked hesitant about disturbing the water.

The creatures were bipedal. They had fur all over their bodies, and wore mean-looking necklaces and clothing made of bone. It was clear at a glance that they wore their garb as a warning to others not to mess with them. They didn't look human, more like purple-skinned apes with deformed faces and huge noses. Their eyes were especially large and pitch-black.

[Slow our pace...] Ferral said warily. [Those creatures likely have excellent night vision.]

[A sensible idea.] Raavul replied.

The party carefully detoured the pool. As they did, Timothy chuckled nervously into his microphone.

"Careful now, Marigold. I'm sure you want to go for a dip, but we'll have to sit this one out, hehe."

He laughed to himself, but he didn't get a response from his girlfriend. After a moment, Timothy frowned. He carefully looked backward, but Marigold was still in the rear, like before. He looked at her for another few seconds.

"Marigold? Hello? Chrona to Marigold! Are you there?"

Marigold lifted her head. "...Huh?"

"Marigold!" Timothy snapped. "Are you *sleeping?!*"

Marigold became a little more alert. "Oh! Um... I just... was resting my eyes..."

Ferral glanced back at Marigold. He hadn't noticed her drowsiness, because he had been focusing on levitating the others while trying to perceive the area around their party. It took all his mental effort to do just this, so he didn't have the energy to spare for other things.

[If you are tired, you should have told us.] Ferral said, his tone one of light anger.

[Yes.] Raavul said, not bothering to look back. [You have endangered the party. What if we were being pursued and your inattentiveness caused us to overlook the presence of possible enemies?]

"How could you be sleepy anyway?" Timothy asked, furrowing his brow. "Didn't you sleep last night? I told you to get a good night's sleep before we left!"

Marigold lowered her head, slightly ashamed. "Kyargh... I'm sorry. I don't know what came over me. I did sleep, yeah. I don't usually get drowsy like this..."

The Psions levitated to a stop. They gently set the others down, then used their methods to sweep the area around them.

Raavul stiffened. [Damn. We've been followed.]

Timothy's blood ran cold. He looked at her helmet, then followed her general gaze, which seemed to be focused somewhere on the path behind them.

[Fifty potential hostiles sneaking in the underbrush behind us.] Ferral said, following his teacher's lead. [We'll need to pick up the pace if we hope to lose them.]

[I cannot sense their visual appearance.] Raavul said, her tone tinged with worry. [I can only sense the movements of the glade. The stealth capabilities of our pursuers exceed the scope of my understanding. We must flee!]

The good news was, the party hadn't been surrounded. If they drastically picked up the pace, Timothy's group might be able to shake their pursuers. The bad news was, they were no longer as incognito as they had previously hoped.

Timothy glowered at his girlfriend underneath his helmet, where she couldn't see. He was rightfully annoyed, and even a bit pissed off. It was one thing if she was tired and had

said something, but she'd put the whole group at serious risk, and they were only a few hours into a possible seven-day mission!

How could she be so irresponsible as to literally fall asleep on the job?!

Timothy exhaled quietly. He kept his thoughts to himself, then turned to Paimon.

"You think we should stand and fight or make a break for it?"

Paimon shook his head. "If we fight, we risk drawing the attention of the watering hole group. Better to pick up the pace, even if it does make us more conspicuous. Let's get a move on."

Raavul and Ferral nodded. Since Paimon was the designated leader, they chose to do as he ordered. A moment later, the trio was lifted up again, but this time, Marigold was made to 'stand' in the middle and Paimon was moved to laying down in the back.

Paimon took out the rifle Fiona had given him. He decided to cradle it in his arms so that if the enemies suddenly attacked from behind, he could hold them off and slow them down, though doing so would definitely alert the denizens of the Dark Forest.

With the new formation prepared, the group set off, deliberately increasing their speed. Paimon watched warily as the enemies behind them fell behind for a while, then picked up their speed when they realized Timothy's party had noticed their presence.

An hour passed. Slowly but surely, the enemies in the rear faded into the background. Paimon eventually lost sight of their heat signatures, and he also stopped being able to see them at all.

"Movement up ahead." Timothy said, causing the others to become more alert. "It's something... big."

Paimon cursed under his breath. The group slowed to a stop and carefully adhered to a tree, with the Psions levitating in place, and the other three grabbing onto the tree with both feet and one hand. Paimon squinted as he looked up ahead into the darkness, using his free hand to hold the rifle defensively.

Demons had incredible night-time eyesight, but their species advantage was dramatically lessened at the lower levels. Belial could see clearly even in pitch-black darkness, but Paimon's vision was much closer to that of a 'peak human', since Paimon was merely a Grunt. He could distinguish movement in the Dark Forest, but he couldn't make out much in the way of details.

As such, even Paimon had to rely on the T-REX for visual clarity. The night-vision feature, coupled with his superior vision, helped make up for his deficits.

Up in the distance, a lumbering behemoth was slowly moving forward, pushing the trees aside as it walked. It was a quadruped covered in leaves and moss. Its exact shape was impossible to make out. Two yellowed tusks stuck out of whatever represented its mouth, even protruding through the leaves hiding its body from view. It was huge, but it made surprisingly little noise, as if it had adapted its biology for stealth rather than power or defense.

[What a strange creature...] Ferral said, his voice low. [Is it an exobeast? Or a Sentient?]

Nobody knew the answer. They merely watched as the creature lumbered past. It took 15 minutes, but eventually the behemoth traveled out of range.

"The ones from before have caught up." Timothy said, gesturing with his free hand in the direction the party just traveled from.

Everyone grimaced in unison.

[Our pursuers are persistent.] Raavul said.

"You think we should make our stand and take them out? Nip the problem in the bud?" Timothy asked.

Raavul hesitated. She looked at Paimon, as did the others.

"Even though there are only five of us, and the enemy numbers around fifty, at least as far as we can determine, we likely have some real advantages." Paimon said. "The enemy is staying low to the ground, while we can take to the tree branches. We have ranged weapons. We can kill several of them if we strike hard."

Paimon shook his head. "But this is a foolish decision. The sound of our attacks will likely draw a lot of attention. We should only fight if we absolutely must. Killing off these foes will save us for now, only to call down a guillotine upon our necks later."

Everyone nodded. Paimon's words were reasonable.

"However," Paimon said, "just because fighting these enemies is a bad idea, that does not mean we cannot use other means."

Once he spoke, everyone realized what he was thinking. The group once again took off, levitated by the Psions. As they flew, Timothy reached into his inventory and took out some materials his mother had provided him. Among them was a ten-gallon tank of gasoline. Intended to provide fuel for fires in survival situations, the gasoline served a different purpose now as Timothy began lightly pouring it behind the group as they traveled.

It didn't take long before Timothy had drawn a 500 meter line of flammable liquid. After that, he lit a match and tossed it into the foliage, causing a fire to spring up behind the party.

With this, the Psions quickened their speed. They raced forward, leaving the newly awakened wall of fire to light up the darkness, causing mayhem as countless screeches and roars erupted from all angles.

Fearful of the consequences of their actions, the group fled as fast as they could. In the distance, they saw huge shadowy shapes descending upon the fire, and those shapes began to violently battle one another. The impact of their attacks sent shockwaves outward, which caused the fire to spread even more quickly than before.

"The creatures here will fight each other?" Timothy asked doubtfully. "I didn't realize that. We could use this to our advantage in the future."

Right after he spoke, Timothy flinched. A window popped up in front of him.

* * *

Deep Forest Marauder defeated.

Acquired: 140 exp. 240 Gold. 1x Deep Forest Marauder remains. Deep Forest Marauder tooth x3.

* * *

Timothy blinked. "Huh?"

It didn't take a rocket scientist to figure out what had happened. He looked backward in shock. "I just got a kill message! The forest fire is counted as me killing the monsters!"

Then he got another message. And another one.

* * *

Deep Forest Marauder x3 defeated.

Acquired: 420 exp. 900 Gold. 3x Deep Forest Marauder remains. Deep Forest Marauder Pelt x1. Deep Forest Marauder Claws x2. Deep Forest Marauder Eyeballs x5.

Forest Crawler Defeated.

Acquired: 90 EXP. 580 Gold. 1x Flint Knife (Common). 4x Darkstones.

Lurking Eye Defeated.

Acquired: 501 EXP. 1400 Gold. Darkvision Skillbook (Common).

* * *

Timothy felt deep shock at first, but gradually, as the kills started to rack up, his emotions turned to excitement, then numbness.

Monsters were dying at an inconceivable rate! Every minute, five or more perished to the flames, and those flames attracted even more monsters who died afterward.

Timothy stared at his Character sheet. He was Level 9 when he entered the Dark Forest, but now, he had reached Level 12. And his EXP continued to climb...

[You have leveled up.]

[You have leveled up.]

[You have leveled up.]

[You have leveled up.]

Timothy stopped focusing on his levels. He simply didn't have time to look through all the awards, so he put them out of mind.

Eventually, the flames either burned out or enemies stopped running into them, or maybe Timothy left the range of the fire and the King Network stopped counting the deaths of the forest denizens as Timothy's credit. Timothy's radical upward growth slowed down until he reached Level 21.

He had gained 12 levels in less than two hours. This was a shocking pace of development, to the point that he was shaking with anxiety. He was happy, no doubt, but the thought that he had leveled up off the deaths of other creatures felt somewhat... morbid.

Timothy made sure to let everyone else know. All of them were in awe, and definitely jealous.

"Kyargh! You think if we all burn this whole forest down, we'll hit level 100??" Marigold asked excitedly.

[Regardless of whether the creatures here are 'real' or not, that seems a vile way to acquire levels.] Raavul said disapprovingly. [Timothy obtained those levels by accident. He cannot be blamed for the creatures throwing themselves into the fire, but if he were to do so again, he would definitely be to blame.]

[I do not believe the creatures here are 'false' or 'fake' lifeforms.] Ferral added. [The fact a Dungeon Break event can cause them to spill into our universe indicates they must truly exist somewhere, somehow. Thus, killing them en-masse for sport or gains can be seen as an act of genocide.]

That made Timothy's mood even worse. "Even if it was an accident, you're right. I didn't want to kill all of them. I thought I'd just scare them away. Now I feel like a monster..."

Timothy looked at his Character page. After killing all the Dark Forest creatures, he had acquired more than 75,000 gold. He didn't have a clear barometer for the value of the gold, but 75,000 sure seemed like a lot!

What's done is done. Timothy thought. *I can't take back all those deaths. I'll just have to make sure I don't do it again. In the meantime, maybe I should visit the Shop to see what I can buy?*

But then, he woke up from his thoughts when his T-REX beeped a warning. "Guys! Movement up ahead. Multiple bogeys."

The party slowed down. Their expressions turned ugly. There appeared to be a massive caravan crossing the forest up ahead. Unlike all the other enemies inside the Dark Forest, these creatures were holding torches, dressed ostentatiously, and wearing armor that looked extremely well-maintained.

One of the creatures sat atop a giant lizard-like steed, while all the others surrounded the noble figure in a protective formation, yet there was no trace of fear in their movements. It was as if they were openly taunting the forest, daring others to come attack them. None took the bait.

Timothy activated his Eye of Yredelemnul skill. He scanned a few of the creatures, but their stat sheets didn't pop up.

* * *

Emissary of Ashenzari - Dark Forest - Supreme Existence

A powerful adherent of the cult of Ashenzari. An elite capable of fighting ten other Sentients at the same time. Fast and strong, their lacking defense is improved by the quality of their armor. Ashenzari's Emissarys possess the power to tap into nature itself, making them especially deadly in dense woodlands.

Warrior of Ashenzari - Dark Forest - Guardian

A high-ranking adherent of the cult of Ashenzari. A powerful warrior who fights to protect their designated Emissary. Capable of entering a Battle Rage, they can rip through the defenses of their enemies, tearing their flesh and bones apart with great ease.

Priest of Ashenzari - Dark Forest - Devotee

A faithful worshiper of Ashenzari. Capable of healing their allies swiftly through Ashenzari's Blessing while also wielding great power through their curse magic. Ashenzari's Priests are capable of peering into the darkness within the hearts of others and snuffing their life out, should that darkness prove oppressive enough.

* * *

"These are strong enemies." Timothy said quietly. "We don't want to fight them. They might be the apex predators of the Dark Forest."

Just as Timothy spoke, the lone Emissary atop the giant lizard suddenly turned its head. The Emissary was wearing a golden mask made in the style of a giant diamond, obscuring its face. But even so, Timothy felt as if he had been spotted.

[A powerful entity has observed your location.]

A warning appeared in front of him, generated by Yredelemnul's Eye. Timothy froze, and his heart nearly stopped.

Another notification appeared.

[A powerful entity has recognized that you are a devotee of a fellow Dark One. The powerful entity has lost interest in you.]

The Emissary looked at Timothy for all of five seconds, then looked away. The procession continued, leaving Timothy sweating nervously until they had passed far, far

out of range.

"Was it just me, or did that strong guy look in our direction?" Marigold asked, levitating behind Timothy. "He was really scary."

[It seems the creature sensed something amiss, but then it lost interest.] Ferral replied.

[We're fortunate they passed us by.] Raavul added. [If we were to fight those monsters, we would have been annihilated. They were all at the peak of mortal strength. Each was stronger than a Demon Emperor.]

Timothy's expression distorted. "What about the one on top of the mount?"

[You would experience great fear if I told you.] Raavul said simply.

Timothy wasn't sure why his Eye couldn't detect the creature's stats. Maybe it was because Ashenzari was one of the 'dark ones'? He didn't know who they were, but they sounded scary. It seemed they also mistook him for a fellow devotee, but he knew he wasn't one.

Timothy thought for a moment, then he remembered that Yredelemnul's Eye stated it once belonged to a 'Dark One.' Could that have been what the Emissary detected?

I'm lucky I had this skill. It caused a misunderstanding that helped us out! Timothy thought.

Obviously, he wasn't a devotee of a 'Dark One', but he did possess a fragment of one individual's power. If it caused strong enemies to avoid him, then the effect was good in his eyes.

Once Ashenzari's procession passed, the group continued onward. They traveled for six more hours without incident, and no enemies pursued them either.

Eventually, everyone came to a stop. They spotted a tree with particularly dense branches, and after making sure no other life forms were nearby, the tired group stopped to make camp for the night.

"Do either of you need to sleep? You've been doing all the work, levitating us around and such." Paimon said to the Psions.

[Psions do not require sleep.] Ferral said. [I am indeed somewhat drained, but a few hours of meditation will restore my mind back to its full capacity.]

[I will take the first watch.] Raavul added. [Ferral, you will meditate, and once you have rested, I will meditate next. I have more energy than you. As your senior, taking the first watch is only natural.]

Timothy was exhausted. He looked at Marigold. She seemed to be full of energy.

"Did you get lots of sleep on the way over here?" Timothy asked, his words sarcastic but also tinged with bitterness.

"I already said I was sorry!" Marigold snapped back. "I don't know why I dozed off. I got plenty of sleep last night, I just felt like my eyelids were really heavy."

Timothy shook his head. "Whatever. Just try not to let it happen again. If you're feeling sleepy, just tell us. If you don't, someone could sneak up on us."

"Sure." Marigold said, but it was clear she was angry about being interrogated like this.

Timothy reached into his inventory and pulled out some sleeping bags and pillows. He offered them to Marigold and Paimon, but Marigold didn't seem too sleepy, and Paimon was a Demon Grunt, so he could probably go another 2 or 3 days without sleep.

Sadly, Timothy, even though he was a Player, was still only a human in the end. He needed his beauty sleep.

As such, he laid his head down and fell fast asleep within minutes.

Half an hour later, Marigold slid over to Paimon's side. He was meditating to rest his mind a little without actually needing to sleep. When he sensed Marigold's presence, Paimon turned to look at her.

"Do you need something?" Paimon asked.

Marigold kept her voice low. "I'm so sorry I fell asleep earlier. I didn't mean to!"

"I know you didn't. Timothy does too. Perhaps the darkness of the forest tricked your senses into thinking it was night-time. Your body reacted accordingly."

"Maybe that's it." Marigold mumbled. "Or maybe I'm just not dependable..."

Marigold sighed. She felt terrible, but she didn't know what to do. She thought the Dungeon would be exciting and fun, but so far all the party had done was run and hide from monsters she couldn't even see properly. It was more boring and irritating than anything else.

"I hope something fun happens soon." Marigold grumbled. "Then I'll be able to show off my worth."

Paimon shook his head.

"Be careful what you wish for."

Part 749: I'm His Emissary

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy slept deeply for six hours. He woke up with a start, only to find that everyone else was awake and either meditating or sitting quietly. His heart momentarily racing, Timothy sat up and looked around.

"Welcome back to the world of the wakeful." Paimon said quietly.

He was lightly teasing Timothy, but Timothy didn't even register the joking tone. He patted his chest and looked around with trembling eyes.

"Hm? Timmy? Something wrong?" Marigold asked, picking up on his odd behavior.

"I fell asleep..." Timothy said.

"Yes. You were quite tired, after a long day running from enemies." Paimon said.

"No. I mean, I fell asleep *way* too easily." Timothy said. He rested his back against the tree and shivered. "I always toss and turn for at least thirty minutes, and that's in a comfy bed. How the hell did I fall asleep so quickly in a situation like this, with danger surrounding us, and also being way up in a tree? I don't exactly have a fear of heights, but I'm not *not* afraid of heights. I should have been at least a little nervous."

Marigold shrugged. "It sounds like you're really underestimating how tired you were to me."

"Yeah?" Timothy challenged. "And you fell asleep not long after we entered the forest even though you really shouldn't have been tired at all. Don't you find *that* a bit strange?"

Paimon and Raavul looked over at the other three. Raavul slightly frowned.

[Now that you mention it, that does seem somewhat... suspicious.] Raavul said. She didn't elaborate.

"Marigold, did you sleep at all?" Timothy asked. "While I was out, I mean."

Marigold looked miffed. She felt as if Timothy were interrogating her again, bringing back her bad mood from earlier. "I wasn't sleepy! I stayed up and kept watch with the others! Jeez, no need to be such a jerk!"

"That's not... not what I'm saying..." Timothy said.

Timothy looked to the right. He looked to the left.

The forest was, as always, eerily silent. Their voices should have spread out quite far, but the Dark Forest seemed to consume noise, making it dissolve into the darkness within seconds.

Timothy shivered again. He rubbed his arms. "Something's not right. Raavul, Ferral, check the area! Are we alone? I feel like I'm being watched."

Raavul raised an eyebrow. Her many eyes and investigative psionics swept a 1000-meter zone around their tree. Her senses were more attuned than all of the others, and she could detect finer details at greater distances than even Ferral.

[Nothing. We're alone for a kilometer in every direction.] Raavul said.

Paimon activated his T-REX. He turned on its various scanning sensors and stood up, turning slowly to surveil every direction he could.

"Nothing." Paimon said. "Timothy... you're not going mad on us, are you?"

Timothy activated his T-REX. He tossed his bedding into his inventory and shakily stood up.

"I'm fucking serious, guys. I feel like I'm about to throw up here. There's something looking at me, and I don't know from what direction."

Timothy suddenly realized something. He activated his best skill, the Eye of Yredelemnul. He looked out into the distance and activated it once, but found nothing. Then he looked a little more to the right...

His heart stopped.

Five trees away, the Eye of Yredelemnul popped up outlines of three *somethings* clinging stealthily to the sides of the tree. For a brief moment, Timothy locked gazes with an amber-eyed creature with vertical slit pupils.

"SHIT!" Timothy screamed inside his T-REX. "They're everywhere! We're surrounded! RUN!"

The others didn't immediately believe him, but the panic in Timothy's voice made Raavul and Ferral react instinctively. They summoned a shield of psionic energy around the group.

As if on cue, objects flew out of the trees from all directions. Javelins, rocks, other primitive projectiles slammed into the hastily formed shield with alarming power, rattling both Psion's bones and making them cry out in pain. It was as if thirty trolls had hammered down on their shield with giant clubs made of stone!

[Aaargh! What power!] Ferral cried.

Timothy continued to look around. The more he activated his Eye, the more he saw these unknown creatures surrounding them. Even at this moment, more were stealthily sneaking through the underbrush and climbing the trees. Their camouflage was so potent that the Psions still couldn't detect them, and neither could the T-REXes.

After the first barrage, a second round flew toward the group. Unable to determine exactly where the hidden creatures were, Raavul and Ferral had to blindly grab the others, yank them off the tree, and dive down toward the foliage below.

It was then that the Psions got their first look at the creatures, as they finally spotted a pair directly below the tree, looking up at the group of non-forest denizens falling toward them. They looked like goblins, but their skin was mottled and green. When they didn't move, they blended in perfectly with the foliage. The only way to spot them was when they moved, by following the trail of their ember-colored eyes.

Raavul and Ferral curved the fall of the group clumsily, but they succeeded in pulling up before they slammed everyone to their deaths against the forest floor. After pulling up, they raced forward, Paimon aiming his rifle around wildly, but unable to spot a single enemy.

Marigold also pulled out a rifle, one that was modified to better fit her larger claws. Her pupils, the eyes of a predator, narrowed to slits as she carefully looked around.

KZAAT!

A bright blue beam of electrical energy fired from the tip of her rifle. It was so bright it caused temporary blindness in anyone looking at Timothy's party from the direction Marigold was facing. Several of the goblin-like creatures screeched as their sensitive eyes conjured tears of pain.

The beam of blue energy struck one of the creatures and instantly lit it on fire, causing it to cry in a high-pitched voice. It leaped into the jungle foliage, spreading fire and flames as it ran.

At this point, Timothy had a brief moment to check the information he'd scanned from these creatures. He quickly looked at it.

* * *

Dark Forest Stalker - Middle Mortal

A powerful species variant of the Goblins. These creatures possess potent camouflage, acute senses of sight, hearing, and smell, and can track their prey for tens of kilometers. Once they mass up in sufficient number, they will strike, leaving their enemy no time to react. Their strength and claws allow them to easily tear flesh from bone.

* * *

Timothy's pupils constricted. Middle Mortals, those were on the same level as Demon Dukes! Each one of these creatures was that strong?! His group didn't have a chance!

Even as they flew away, the Dark Forest Stalker Marigold had lit on fire hadn't actually died. It eventually put out the flames on its body and simply curled up on the ground, trembling in pain. Since it didn't die, she received no experience, gold or items.

She couldn't shoot it again, either. The Psions were flying the party away as fast as they could. With no other choice, Marigold simply took aim again and shot another bright blue beam of energy out, causing another Stalker to scream in agony. She shot two more times, but unfortunately missed, before shooting again and hitting a third target.

Frustratingly, no matter how many of the bastards she shot, the hardy little creatures didn't actually die. This caused her rage to build.

Timothy and Paimon weren't sitting on their laurels either. Timothy reached into his inventory and pulled out a couple of flashbang grenades. He threw them in different directions behind the party, and after several seconds, they exploded, stunning the Dark Forest Stalkers who were nearby. Their senses were far more acute than those of humans, so the feedback they received was also much more painful as well.

Paimon couldn't see the enemies at first, but his demonic vision, coupled with the T-REX night vision, eventually allowed him to spot the tiny glowing orbs of light that represented the eyes of the Dark Forest Stalkers. He started firing his rifle whenever he thought he saw movement.

Surprisingly, Paimon's shots connected a few times. He wasn't able to kill the goblins, even with the astounding power of his AR-15, one of the most powerful weapons from Ancient Earth, but he was able to cause them a lot of pain and force them to retreat in a panic.

Still, the spears flung by the Stalkers continued to fly toward the party as they hovered forward at high speeds. The number of Stalkers in the area must have exceeded a thousand! Timothy had no idea how the group would have survived if they had waited on that branch any longer. It seemed the enemies had almost reached their target density and were planning to kill his party in one swift attack.

Minutes passed. A spear crashed into Marigold's body and rattled her bones, but her T-REX absorbed the worst of the impact. A deep gash was carved along her chest, making her roar in pain. The spear fell to the undergrowth below, and more nanites rushed in to fill up the gap. Her Spectre suit was not suited for defense, so the injury she suffered was worse than if she'd been wearing a Rhino or Thundercat variant.

Marigold gritted her teeth, her long jaw pressing together tightly as tears welled up in her eyes, along with anger. She fired more beams into the forest, lighting the area up behind the group as the Stalkers leaped from tree to tree to pursue Timothy's group.

Fires spread left and right. The forest started to burn again, and soon, even Marigold started to get some kills. Weaker creatures approached from the rear, attracted by the heat and light. Their dying screams produced EXP and gold for her, but she was too busy shooting enemies to notice.

Timothy opened his inventory. He blinked in surprise. "What the hell- where is it?!"

He scanned his inventory five times. The weapon he wanted... wasn't there! Had it been stolen?

"Where's the goddamn Sword of Justice??" Timothy cried out.

Had he stupidly forgotten it? Had he left it at home like a complete idiot?

An ominous premonition swallowed Timothy's mind. He checked his stat sheet, and his eyes turned bloodshot with rage.

All his stats had dropped by -1!

He hadn't even gotten to use the goddamn sword, and it had already broken, cursing him with -1 to all stats for 24 hours!

"Umi! What the hell, why did the sword break?! I didn't even kill any innocents with it!" Timothy complained.

Umi's tiny speck of light flickered into existence in front of Timothy's face.

"**This is why you are an inferior biological. The sword stated that if you killed an innocent, it would break. It did not say the sword would break if the sword itself killed an innocent. You haphazardly lit a forest on fire. Do you really think all the creatures that died were guilty of great sins?**"

Timothy's face fell. "Fuck! I don't know whether I'm more mad at you or more mad at myself for not realizing- goddammit! Looks like I have no choice!"

With the Sword of Justice broken, Timothy was a lot weaker now, and this meant his damage output had dropped considerably. With great reluctance, he pulled out the relatively ordinary Longsword he'd acquired from a Lootbox.

Timothy's best combat skill was Divine Blaze. He realized that in this particular situation, it would have terrific results in dealing with the enemies pursuing them.

Even though Timothy couldn't reach the Stalkers that were clearly out of melee range, he still shouted at the Psions. "Change the formation! Single file, wide-stance. Me in the middle, Paimon and Marigold on the sides!"

The Psions nodded. They didn't have a lot of attention to spare, what with their low Psionic levels, but they were able to change the formation from a diamond-shape to a line-shape. The Psions flew on the outside, with the three others lined up between them.

Like this, Timothy tapped into his mana. He could enchant his weapon with roaring flames at the cost of one mana per minute. He had enough mana to last 45 minutes if he cast no other spells.

And so, that was what he did. Timothy lit his sword on fire and started sweeping the forest below as they fled, deliberately lighting another massive blaze to slow down the pursuit of his enemies.

Screeches of rage came from behind. The Stalkers started to slow their speed as they continually came in contact with foliage and trees lit aflame. Their piercing shrieks, mixed with the scorching heat and bright light drew even more monsters toward the group.

Soon, Timothy heard a stomach curdling roar. A powerful creature, five meters tall, wielding a giant wooden club, rushed toward the Stalkers. It started grabbing the nearest

ones up and stuffing them into its mouth while the Stalkers howled like terrified apes.

Whatever this creature was, it seemed to be the predator of the Stalkers. Not just one of them appeared, but five! The massive giants started roaring battle cries and grabbing at the Stalkers, spreading mass panic among their ranks. Before long, the Stalkers fled in all directions, no longer chasing Timothy's party.

[Douse your flames.] Raavul said. [Let us attempt to return to stealth.]

Timothy did as Raavul ordered, and Marigold also stopped firing her gun. Before long, the flames behind them turned into distant specks of light. The screams of Stalkers and other dying creatures faded away.

Timothy continued to accumulate kills, but the monsters that died were relatively weak and ordinary. They didn't give him much EXP.

Marigold was different. She also shot up in levels, eventually reaching Level 13! This was a huge increase, albeit not at Timothy's level. She clapped her claws excitedly and gave Timothy a toothy grin.

"It's not as fun as killing them myself, but leveling up is still leveling up!" Marigold crowed. She casually used a Full Heal to regenerate the injury she'd suffered from the spear.

The Psions tightened up the formation. They continued flying low to the ground, their expressions dark.

[That was close.] Ferral said. [If Timothy hadn't woken up, we might have all perished. Timothy, how did you spot those creatures when even Raavul could not?]

"Yredelemnul's Eye." Timothy said. "Those monsters were called Dark Forest Stalkers. They're a sort of super-goblin variant, or something. I don't know much about them, but apparently they were all as strong as Demon Dukes. That's why we basically couldn't kill them."

[How frightening.] Raavul said, her tone emotionless. [Demon Dukes are roughly as strong as 4th Level Psions. An army of a thousand... if they were to fall upon the Seven Hells, even the demons would have a difficult time killing them. And that group we faced was unlikely to be the full extent of their species.]

"If they only had a hundred thousand more among their ranks, I would be surprised." Paimon said, his tone deadpan. "There could be millions of those creatures crawling

around this forest. We simply can't see them."

Timothy shuddered. He activated his Eye again and again, but he didn't spot any other Lurkers hiding in the darkness. Not for now, anyway.

As the group flew, Timothy looked at Marigold. Then he lowered his eyes and looked away.

"Hey... Marigold?"

"Yeah? What?" Marigold asked, crossing her arms. It was clear she was still angry.

"I owe you an apology." Timothy said. "It wasn't your fault you fell asleep. I realized it after I woke up. Those creatures... they must have cast a spell on us or something. After I set that fire the first time, I killed a lot of monsters. My stats were debuffed, and what happened to you happened to me. I fell asleep too. So... it wasn't your fault you passed out, and I shouldn't have jumped on you like that. I'm sorry."

Marigold looked at the side profile of Timothy's helmet. Her expression softened. "Oh... well, if it's like that... yeah. Um. I got pretty angry too. I'm sorry for lashing out at you too."

The wound wasn't healed, and trust would require time to rebuild, but it was a start. Timothy and Marigold both heaved sighs of relief. They felt a lot better after apologizing to one another, and a lot of the tension faded away.

The group continued to move.

Since the Psions were tireless, and since Timothy knew the Stalkers would be able to pursue them for tens of kilometers, this meant that laying down and sleeping wasn't really possible. Staying in one spot for too long could bring about another disaster. Enemies lurked everywhere, with the group frequently needing to change directions as they traveled.

"Hey, guys?" Timothy said, at one point on the second day of their expedition. "Which way are we going?"

[North.] Raavul answered.

"Right now? We're flying that way *right now*?" Timothy asked. "Because my T-REX's HUD says we're going west."

"Oh, huh, mine says north-west." Marigold added.

"...Mine says north." Paimon said, frowning.

[Mine says west.] Ferral said. [I hadn't actually looked at it in a while. I was following Raavul's lead.]

[Mine says north...] Raavul said. She glanced at Timothy. [Why do all our instruments show we are traveling different directions?]

"I... don't know..." Timothy answered. "Maybe the forest itself is messing with our sensors? Maybe it's enemy interference?"

A moment of silence followed.

[Timothy, don't you have an item that always points north?] Ferral asked.

Timothy blinked. "Oh, yeah! I almost forgot."

He reached into his inventory and retrieved an item.

Tin Compass [Item] [Common] [Utility]

Points north. Always. Even underground, underwater, and in dimensions where north does not conventionally exist. In those cases, it points toward the nearest approximation of north, which is sometimes unsettling. Does not interact with any navigation skills. Cannot be improved further. It simply points north.

The group slowed their speed until they came to a stop. Timothy waited for a moment, and the needle eventually pointed in a certain direction.

"It's actually east??" Timothy asked. "We were all wrong! If the compass is correct, we're going almost entirely the wrong way!"

Paimon scowled. "If that's the case, we might have been going off-course for a long while. We still have a deadline to adhere to. We can only hope that if we reorient ourselves and get back on track, we'll reach the edge of the forest on time."

The group adjusted their T-REX's internal compasses, but Timothy didn't want to take a chance, so he kept the Tin Compass in his grip and periodically started checking it every few hours.

Time passed again. It was now the fourth day of the Dungeon expedition.

The group stumbled into many different encounters. They ended up having to fight a powerful beast similar to the ones that ate the Lurkers, and that fight took them an hour

to win. Timothy ended up beaten and battered, and Marigold wasn't much better off. Ferral earned an entire level-up off the fight, bringing him to Level 8.

At one point, they accidentally found a massive city in their path, a city built in the treetops, glowing with divine radiant light. The creatures living there appeared to be members of the Ashenzari cult, so Timothy's party had to take a huge detour around the city so as to not be seen by potential enemies.

Timothy was almost tempted to see if they could enter the city. Didn't that Emissary recognize him as an ally? Maybe Ashenzari and Yredelemnul were actually quite close and Timothy could speed up the journey by passing through?

Naturally, Timothy did not follow up on this idea. There was no reason to potentially throw away everyone's lives for a nebulous reward.

Unfortunately, as the group circled around the great city, a bright light erupted from the darkness. It shone directly on Timothy's party, startling and blinding them. Even the Psions were not immune to the blinding effect. Raavul and Ferral both ground to a halt, lifting their hands to cover their eyes as a single figure strode forward, a brilliant staff held aloft in its hand. The figure pointed the staff of light toward the group.

"Eratti, vishtuul mata Yredelemnul." The bipedal creature said.

It lowered the staff, causing the light to dim. When Timothy's party regained their sight, they saw a powerful and imposing alien-looking creature with pale white skin, flared cheekbones, two pitch-black eyes, and a completely smooth head. The back of the creature's head was similar in shape to a squid, or perhaps an arrowhead. The creature's skin seemed slightly wet, as if it were native to an aquatic biome, not a forest. The creature wore a ceremonial dress, but the lack of armor did nothing to obscure the fact it was an extremely powerful life form.

When it spoke, Timothy immediately understood its words.

"Greetings, followers of Yredelemnul." The creature said, its voice somewhat feminine. "We have witnessed your arrival in the Dark Forest. We wish to invite you to our land."

Timothy's heart skipped a beat.

This was an idea he had already thought of, but one he had shaken off as irresponsible and dangerous.

Now, it seemed he had no choice but to go along with the creature's wishes.

Timothy shivered. Since he was the only one who could speak, he had to take the role of diplomat in this situation. He projected his voice outward, through the T-REX's exterior speakers.

"Ah, greetings. I am Timothy... Emissary of Yredelemnul." Timothy said, cringing as he spoke. He really hoped he hadn't just committed a grave faux pas by labeling himself an Emissary. Maybe he should have said 'friend'? Ally? Servant? *Slave*??

"Emissary of Yredelemnul? Your power is lacking, but you carry a proper fragment of the Dark One inside you." The creature said. "My name is Sylphid. I am the 32nd Emissary of Ashenzari. What rank might you be?"

Timothy hesitated.

Sylphid could be lying. What if there were only one or two Emissaries and this was a test to see if Timothy knew such basic information? What if there were hundreds, and claiming he were of a position too high might expose his ignorance?

Timothy had too little information to work with. In fact, he had basically nothing!

A fraction of a second passed. Timothy's eyes flashed as he quickly came to a decision. He puffed up his chest and snorted.

"You are quite presumptuous, Sylphid. I am a Secret Emissary of Yredelemnul. My status goes beyond the concept of 'ranks'."

His words came out fluently, in the exact same language as the one Sylphid spoke. Sylphid looked the armored young man up and down. It was clear even without seeing his face or body that Timothy was not a member of the species among the Dark Ones' home galaxy, but the Dark Ones had long extended their reach out to multiple galaxies. It was well within the realm of possibility that, among the thousands of species throughout all those galaxies, there was one which resembled Timothy.

The bigger question Sylphid faced was... who were the other unknown Sentients traveling along with the young man? Sylphid had not seen such a motley crew in her entire life. Especially the one with the extremely elongated skull. It looked wildly different from the others.

"A Secret Emissary? I have not heard of such a thing before." Sylphid said.

"Well. You have now." Timothy retorted, crossing his arms and assuming what he hoped was a heroic pose. "I possess a powerful fragment of my liege. It was given to me in

preparation for his future plans. You are unworthy to know such secrets."

Sylphid did not cower away. Instead, her eyes lit up in interest. "Is that so? I'm growing more interested in you all the time. Won't you and your servants come along with me?"

Timothy blinked. *Servants*? Did she think Paimon and the other were his lackeys? That must be the case.

He wanted to refuse... but Sylphid was much more powerful than all of them put together. He used the Eye to check her description, and what he saw nearly made him break his 'powerful expert' illusion from pure fear.

* * *

Sylphid, Emissary of Ashenzari - Dark Forest - Supreme Existence

A powerful adherent of the cult of Ashenzari. An elite capable of fighting ten other Sentients at the same time. One of the highest ranking Emissaries among Ashenzari's Devoted. Ashenzari's Emissaries possess the power to tap into nature itself, making them especially deadly in dense woodlands.

* * *

It wasn't the same description as the other Emissary. That told Timothy that Sylphid was not the gold-mask wearing Emissary he had seen previously.

Even so, if he went with her, there was a chance they might run into the gold-masked Emissary. Whether that would be good or bad news was anyone's guess.

"Allow me to deliberate with my party." Timothy eventually said.

Sylphid cocked her head. She levitated in the air, a long silvery tail swishing back and forth behind her. She made no motion to stop him, so Timothy took her silence as an 'okay'.

He turned around and switched to internal comms.

"So... this is the situation." Timothy said quietly.

He brought the others up to speed, and even though he couldn't see their expressions, he sensed from their body language that some of them were not happy about this development.

"You're playing with fire." Paimon warned. "We cannot delay. If a dungeon break occurs, all the monsters in the Dark Forest could break out into Chrona. Everyone we know would die."

"I don't disagree, and time is obviously of the essence, but do YOU want to tell the scary Emissary lady 'no'?" Timothy challenged.

Paimon flicked his eyes to look at Sylphid. She patiently levitated in the air, waiting to hear Timothy's verdict.

"I dunno. She seems nice!" Marigold chirped. "Maybe we can get a good night's sleep before we set out again?"

Timothy wanted to rebuke Marigold, but they'd been traveling for four days straight now, and they only had three more days before the quest failed. He wanted some beauty sleep too, but he didn't want to jeopardize the mission.

[I want to go inside.] Ferral suddenly said.

"Huh? You do?" Timothy asked, slightly stunned.

[Yes. This species interests me. I want to explore and see the wider world. If I shy away from every dangerous situation, then what wonders will I ever witness? I believe we might even find the exit to the forest faster if we probe for information from this female.]

Raavul lifted her chin slightly. [I am also interested in learning more about Ashenzari. We cannot overpower Sylphid, so we might as well accept her hospitality. Her gaze is warm, and I sense no malice. I am interested in learning more about her species.]

With that, there were three 'yes' votes, one 'no' from Paimon, and Timothy was 50/50 in either direction.

"Screw it. I guess I'll just say yes, then." Timothy said.

He turned back around, then opened up his helmet to reveal his face. Sylphid finally got a good look at him for the first time and was surprised. She didn't recognize Timothy's species at all.

"Sylphid. We thank you for your generous offer. My people and I are on an important mission, but I would very much like to experience the culture of Ashenzari's followers and compare it with that of my liege. This is my first time meeting your kind, so I hope you will forgive me if myself or my followers commit any minor errors."

Sylphid was pleased with the weaker Emissary's respectful tone. It was good that he wasn't too arrogant and knew his place. If he truly had a seed of a Dark One inside him, then he could become a formidable powerhouse someday. It would be a huge waste not to befriend him now, while he was still vulnerable!

"Ashenzari welcomes you. Please follow me into the Golden Glade." Sylphid said, smiling sweetly at Timothy.

Timothy's face flushed. It was only now, looking at Sylphid with his unfiltered eyes, that he realized she was actually... extremely beautiful!

Behind him, Marigold's gaze flickered with uncertainty.

Drat, she's a threat! Marigold thought. *A huge threat!!*

Part 750: The Golden Glade

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Sylphid was a graceful Emissary, one with seductive curves, and a pale white squid-like skin texture. Her long tail swished back and forth as she walked. Her eyes were completely pitch black, so one could never be entirely sure about where she was looking, except by inferring based on the direction her head was aimed. Her hands had distinct fingers, but her feet were mostly webbed, with five individual claw nubs poking out at the tips. It was clear she was a life form that was heavily adapted to life in the water.

She wore golden robes which were made of tree fibers. The robes looked extravagant, and they perfectly suited her, drawing any hot-blooded man's eyes to her figure.

Timothy fell into step beside her as the group landed on the ground and walked toward the nearby city known as the Golden Glade. It was truly massive in terms of width, and the treetops even rose many stories higher to shield the city's tallest buildings from the light of the outside world.

The city glowed with golden light, golden trim, golden decorations, golden everything! Where there wasn't gold, the outer city zones were mostly painted black, but the inner zones were painted white. It drew a strong contrast that made the outer city zones seem softer and less visible than the inner ones, which were far more ostentatious.

Timothy's stomach clenched up as his group approached the outer city limits. Surprisingly, the city did not have a wall surrounding it. Houses simply started to appear, gradually becoming denser and more numerous as they drew closer.

"Why aren't there any walls? Any guards?" Timothy asked.

Sylphid turned her head and gave him a cute look out of the corner of her eye.

"What fool would attack us? We are the strongest existence in the Dark Forest." Sylphid said coolly. "No matter what creatures you may have encountered during your passage, they would tremble in fear when facing our weakest soldiers. Any who attempt to poach our outermost civilians would be hunted and down and exterminated within the day. Thus, we have no need to visibly defend ourselves."

Timothy was surprised. "How strong are your soldiers compared to me?"

Sylphid chuckled. Her tail waved playfully. "You ask funny questions, hyuu-man. Unless you are concealing a tremendous power within that light frame of yours, I fear your entire group would be no match for the weakest soldier in the Golden Glade. Perhaps a demonstration is in order? Walk with me to the training grounds."

Timothy wanted to reject her, but Sylphid didn't seem to know how to take 'no' for an answer. He tried to phrase his refusals in the most roundabout way possible, but she just ignored him and dragged the others along.

Before long, the group of six entered the inner city. It was at this point they started to pass by heavily armored soldiers. These soldiers wore ostentatious gold and white or gold and black suits of armor. Their heads and faces were fully covered, and only the tiniest patches of skin were visible through tiny gaps in the joins of their armor. Timothy had no idea what alloy the armor was made of, but it was clear it was extremely durable.

Unlike his father, Timothy wasn't too familiar with alloys, ores, and other compositional materials. He wasn't much of a creator, since he'd spent his childhood playing games. It was only natural he'd be lacking his father's learned eye for such things.

"Sylphid, if you don't mind my asking," Timothy said, as they neared the training grounds, "what species are your people, exactly? What do you call yourselves?"

Sylphid gave him another curious glance. "You don't know? Since when was the name of Ashenzari's Chosen not common knowledge?"

"We... come from a distant galaxy." Timothy hesitantly explained. "I used unique spatial magic to travel here. My comrade, Ferral, is quite interested in learning about other cultures."

"You are able to pass through the Unknown to reach other galaxies?!" Sylphid gasped lightly. She gazed at Timothy with even more interest than before. "I suppose it is possible if you possess His power... since you are not yet Cosmics, the Galactic Barriers will not stop you."

Timothy wanted to ask what she meant, but he thought such a question could invite trouble, so he ignored it.

"Ah, yes." Timothy said. "Therefore, I am not too familiar with the species in galaxies outside my own."

"I see. Well, it's no secret or anything." Sylphid said, smiling charmingly. "My people are known as Sequids. We are, of course, the purest descendants of the Dark Ones. Ashenzari's Chosen inherit the direct bloodline of Ashenzari himself. You and your companions, by contrast, do not look very similar to the typical Dark One..."

Even though it was plain to see that Sylphid seemed to still harbor some suspicions, she didn't press Timothy too hard. It was clear that just by possessing a shard of a Dark One, no matter how strange Timothy was, he possessed a strong level of legitimacy in the eyes of Ashenzari's Emissaries.

"Is it rare for Emissaries to possess a shard of the Dark Ones?" Timothy carefully asked, slightly shifting the conversation.

"Indeed, it is highly irregular." Sylphid said. "It means a Dark One has given you a portion of their power. For a Ruler to do this, the recipient must possess incredible potential, or some other compelling attribute. Ah, look, we've arrived."

She led the group up a flight of stairs into a brightly illuminated Colosseum where hundreds of warriors, male and female, were sparring against one another. All of them wore black and gold heavy armor, and they fought in pairs, one versus one. At periodic intervals, there were white and gold armored elites surveying the recruits, shouting orders and disciplining their recruits, tempering their minds.

Timothy gritted his teeth. The troops below were the newest, rawest, weakest recruits who hadn't even formally entered the military properly yet. They still wore the black and gold armor, which meant they were part of the Lesser Echelon, something he had quickly picked up on.

Even so, when their axes, swords, spears, maces, and other similar weapons struck the armor and shields of their sparring partners, shockwaves roared outward. The constant sound of weapons banging against armor was deafening, like listening to a constant hailstorm of artillery! How the recruits managed to hear a single word their commanders spoke was beyond him.

All of a sudden, the training grounds came to a stop. All the recruits slowed their attacks, then assumed disciplined postures as they turned and looked upward at... Timothy and the rest.

"Emissary present!" One of the elite commanders shouted. He quickly bowed toward her and punched his fist into his palm in a respectful salute. "Lady Sylphid! It is our

honor to receive your presence!"

"Carry on." Sylphid said, her usually warm and cute tone suddenly shifting to one of a domineering ruler. Her eyes become cold as she looked down on the soldiers below. "I am only casually showing off the glory of the Golden Grove to some new friends I've made. As you were."

"Yes, Lady Sylphid!" The commander shouted. Like this, the troops quickly returned to their previous sparring, only now Timothy noticed that their attacks were more frenzied than before, as if to put on a good show for the Emissary.

He glanced at Sylphid out of the corner of his eye. "You seem to be quite high up in the hierarchy here."

"Hmph!" Sylphid said, returning to her previous girly demeanor. It was as if she'd become a different person again. "A bunch of groveling weaklings, I have to maintain a fierce attitude before them. It's not the same as when I get to speak to an equal. I am allowed to relax my guard a little in the presence of a fellow Emissary."

"Ah, I see." Timothy said, smiling once again.

Every so often, as they chatted, Timothy would explain some of what was happening to the others, but it was clear he wasn't doing a great job. They were missing 60% or more of the context of his and Sylphid's conversation.

Steam metaphorically started to pour out of Marigold's ears. She didn't like that some new girl was getting close to her man, and Timothy seemed oblivious to Sylphid's charms. The problem was, anything she said, Sylphid just ignored. Marigold wasn't able to speak Sylphid's language, and neither were the others.

"Don't you guys see a problem with this situation?" Marigold hissed.

"Of course I do." Paimon said, his voice low. "I objected to coming here, but nobody listened to me. Now we have to pray we'll be able to break free and make it to our destination in time."

[I am quite enjoying this side-journey.] Ferral said, his eyes revealing a rare trace of excitement. All the sights and sounds were enthralling to him. He particularly enjoyed the exotic tree-based architecture of the Golden Grove, the treehouses suspended high in the sky, and the color scheme of the two city partitions.

[Whatever these creatures are, they are not simple.] Raavul said evenly. [I am learning a lot about their culture. If these 'Sequids' attacked the Milky Way, we would suffer a disaster only slightly less fearsome than the Kolvaxians. Other galaxies are not to be underestimated.]

Timothy continued following Sylphid around. She led the group to the gardens, where beautiful alien flowers wound around smaller trees and arches to create beautiful and somber sights for weary travelers. She led them to the Prophet's Eye, a beautiful blue pool of water that glowed with radiant light year round. She even brought them to the Chaos Gate, a surprisingly sinister room with dozens of statues surrounding a crackling gateway imbued with dark energy.

"This is a chamber empowered by the purest energy of our deity, Dark God Ashenzari." Sylphid explained. "Through this gate, one can travel across the galaxy, even potentially entering Ripspace. But those who survive when they enter are few in number, and even fewer return intact. Across the thousands who have taken the Final Vows for our god, less than one in ten thousand have ever made it back to the Dark Forest."

"Ripspace, huh?" Timothy muttered. He vaguely recalled that his mother had mentioned it once or twice in the past, but his memory was hazy. "What is Ripspace, exactly?"

Sylphid gave him another one of her strange looks. She remained silent for a few moments before explaining.

"Ripspace is one of the only known ways to traverse the cosmos, prior to the beginning of the Galaxy Wars. Even once the Great Game begins, Ripspace is still a safer way of traveling than by crossing the Unknown."

"You said only one in ten thousand return intact." Timothy pointed out. "That sounds pretty damn unsafe to me."

"If the goal is to someday return, then the odds are indeed quite awful." Sylphid acknowledged. "However, if the goal is instead never to return, then Ripspace is not too bad. Those who merely intend to cross to a distant location will have much better odds of success."

Sylphid fell silent for a moment.

"There is one last place I would like to show you, but... it is not appropriate for your companions to join us. It is a location limited only to Emissaries like us. It is a sacred domain. Are you interested in following me there?"

Timothy hesitated. He wasn't eager to break away from his friends. How would he remember everything Sylphid said in order to tell them? He was already missing a lot of details. He'd be lucky to remember five, even ten percent if he had to store it all away for next time.

"Ahh, it's not that I don't want to, but my companions and I do need to return to our mission. We are truly grateful for the hospitality you've shown us. Today, you've opened my eyes to the beauty of Ashenzari. Still, we would like to continue our journey."

Sylphid stroked her soft chin for a moment. "Mmm. I see. I apologize, Emissary Timothy. I *have* been taking up too much of your time, but this place is... it is quite precious to me. How about this? I will show you the sacred location, and then I will give you a parting gift before sending you on your way. Is this agreeable?"

Once again, Timothy paused, feeling conflicted. Sylphid had been quite kind, showing him around. Timothy wasn't totally oblivious to the fact his girlfriend was getting progressively more and more jealous, but on the other hand, was he supposed to tell an existence way stronger than him 'no'? Sylphid seemed nice, but he had to admit he was afraid of pissing her off.

"Let me... discuss it with the others."

Timothy said.

"Of course." Sylphid said, blinking her dark black eyes.

Timothy carefully turned and walked over to the others. He explained the situation, noticing the glare his girlfriend was giving him.

"So she wants to take you off for some 'private time', huh?" Marigold chuffed. "Well, why don't you jump into her arms then?! Forget me! I don't mean anything to you at all. I'm just a stupid ugly smelly crocodile, I can't compare to some exotic alien beauty."

Timothy's shrank his neck at her words. "Come on, Marigold, I'm loyal, I'm not thinking like that at all. You're getting jealous for no reason. I want to get us out of here, and this solves the situation..."

"Whatever!" Marigold snapped. "Do what you want. Run off with some hussy. I'm clearly overthinking it! Must be because I'm a slow, stupid croc!"

"Marigold's words are rich in anger, but they have some bearing in reality." Paimon warned. "We do not know this woman's true nature. You are putting a lot of trust in someone you only met an hour ago. If she intended to hurt you..."

"If she wanted to hurt me, the rest of you couldn't stop her anyway." Timothy pointed out. "None of us are a match for her weakest soldiers, let alone Sylphid herself."

"It's not HURTING you I'm worried about!" Marigold complained. "Kyargh! I'm sure PAIN will be the last thing that seductress makes you feel!!"

Timothy grimaced. "Do you really want me to turn her down, then? We're lucky to have made it this far."

Marigold finally hesitated. "Well... yes! But like, do it tactfully! It can't be that hard!"

Timothy groaned. He didn't want to make his girlfriend jealous, and she was right in that it was clear Sylphid's intentions weren't entirely noble.

In the end, Timothy had to prioritize his friends over a new acquaintance.

Timothy turned to look at Sylphid with a pained expression. "Ah, Sylphid, forgive me. My friends, they... they really wish to leave. We are on a tight deadline."

Sylphid's head flicked from Timothy's direction over to the others, then back again. "The yellow-scaled female... is she a sexual partner of yours?"

"Cough cough cough!!" Timothy choked on his saliva. He did not expect Sylphid to utter such crude and blunt words. "Y-yes! She is my, um, my girlfriend. We've been together for quite a while."

"I see. And she is... jealous of me? Does she believe I have impure designs on you?" Sylphid asked quietly.

"Uhh, I mean, I uh... *yes*?" Timothy said, squeezing the last word out through his teeth. "Um... do you?"

"By no means. You may reassure her that I will take a vow on Ashenzari not to attempt any act of fornication with you." Sylphid said, bowing her head respectfully. "We are Emissaries. Such acts harm the relations of our gods. My body must stay sanctified in order to bring honor to Ashenzari."

"Oh. Is that so?" Timothy asked, though the question was more rhetorical than anything else.

After a moment, he turned back to the others and repeated what Sylphid had said. Even so, Marigold's expression didn't change.

"Great, so she vows not to jump your bones! Well, I'll just take her word on it then!"

"That is quite a venomous vow." Paimon said. "For devout religious types like these, a vow on their god is extremely solemn. I would not dare to call her a liar. It would be a terrible breach of decorum."

[I concur.] Raavul said. [Since she has vowed on her god's name, I do not see the harm in one last visit. This could be a good chance to observe the secrets of extragalactic civilizations.]

[I wish I could go with Timothy.] Ferral said wistfully. [I wish to see Ashenzari's sacred chamber for myself.]

Marigold once again was outvoted. Seeing that she wouldn't get her way, she turned on her heel and stormed away. It didn't matter if Sylphid made a vow or not, Marigold simply didn't trust a man-stealing hussy no matter what she said!

Timothy turned back to Sylphid. "I'm sorry. My girlfriend really doesn't... trust you. I'm rather embarrassed."

"No. It is fine." Sylphid replied. "I am quite inexperienced in the relations between sexes, but I can vaguely understand her distrust. If you wish to depart, then you may leave. I do not wish to put you in an uncomfortable position."

Timothy hesitated, yet again. He saw Sylphid's earnest expression and compared it with Marigold's sulking, angry one. It wasn't that he didn't understand his girlfriend's reaction, but for Pete's sake, he was supposed to be an Emissary speaking to a fellow Emissary. Did she have to drag her mind through the gutter all the time?

Wasn't he his own man? Did he have to pass on things just because his girlfriend didn't like them?

Was he Timothy, or was he 'Timothy, property of Marigold'?

That thought hardened his heart. After a long moment of thinking, Timothy shook his head. "No, I should apologize to you. You've been nothing but kind to me and my friends.

Take me to your Sacred Chamber. Since you've vowed on Ashenzari, I will not disrespect you any further."

"Truly?!" Sylphid asked, her eyes lighting up. She clapped her hands happily. "I am pleased that you have changed your mind! Do not worry, once you see the glory of Ashenzari, you will understand the true beauty of being an Emissary!"

With that, Timothy left his party behind.

He was alone in potential enemy territory. But Timothy was not afraid.

Timothy glanced at his stats as he walked. He had leveled up 11 times. He was level 21 now. He had acquired many new options, and had even ruminated on the possibilities while flying with the Psions over the last couple of days. He hadn't activated any of his level-up options yet, since he wanted to wait until he was back home, but the option was there, nevertheless, merely a thought away.

Among these rewards were several chances to level up two Skills at once.

If I end up being cornered, I might have to empower my Divine Blaze skill to drastically raise my striking power. Or maybe I should focus on defense? Speed? Hmm.

Sylphid led Timothy toward a giant tree located in the center of the Golden Grove, known as the Ancestor Tree, which the entire city was built around. The closer they drew, the more shocked Timothy felt. The Ancestor Tree's trunk was nearly two kilometers in diameter. It rose all the way up to the top of the forest roof, and its greenery at the top was likely the shroud that kept the sun at bay.

There were tens of thousands of buildings constructed around the tree's trunk, with stairways the width of six-lane hallways winding around the Ancestor Tree at various intervals. Suspension bridges linked one giant branch after another together, allowing people alternative routes if they wished to traverse the Golden Grove's most spread-out vertical living space.

In addition to the structures built on the side of the tree and atop the giant, thick branches, there were also buildings hanging from chains, which presumably required either elevator access to reach, or wings. There were alcoves cut into the trunk, presumably leading into living spaces carved within the tree's interior.

"How impressive..." Timothy said out loud. "This is the most beautiful city I've ever seen."

"Thank you." Sylphid said. "My people have labored over countless eras to create the most impressive, powerful, and grandest city in all of the Dark Forest. Even outside the Dark Forest, other Dark Ones would not dare to slander our work. Everything we do is for the glory of Ashenzari."

They continued to approach the tree. As the pair walked, Timothy thought about everything he'd learned about Sylphid.

She was a religious zealot, true, but she had strong feelings about her purpose in life. Timothy was just winging his life, doing whatever came to his mind, often aimlessly, but Sylphid approached reality as if she was born to serve a purpose. It gave her a feeling of fulfillment, a reason to live, a reason to improve herself at all costs. She didn't only serve Ashenzari, but also the people and society around her.

Timothy had no strong beliefs. The King Network wanted him to someday overthrow the Volgrim Empire, and he'd sure like to become a great Hero like his father was, but neither of those could be classified as a 'grand purpose'. They were simply aspirational goals. They did give his life some meaning, but not the spiritually rich purpose someone like Sylphid lived for.

The young man certainly didn't think Sylphid was better than him because she had a grand purpose, and he didn't think she was worse than him just because some might consider her a deluded religious zealot. She was simply... different. He and her had their own viewpoints, and that meant they could engage in interesting, nuanced discussions.

Sylphid led him into a large entry way that tunneled down into the Golden Grove's Ancestor Tree. The pathway expanded, traveling through great halls of marble and stone carefully crafted by ancient artisans, tastefully applied with aesthetic care on the tree's inner walls, with patterns that sparked imagination.

There were countless statues erected, each one of strange creatures Timothy actually found somewhat... disturbing. It seemed to him that the Dark Ones primarily consisted of a series of aquatic species. Tentacles were prominent on their hands, their faces, even their entire lower bodies. A theme he quickly noticed was that many of them had octopus and squid-like appearances in one way or another, but even whale, dolphin, and shark-like creatures were seen among their ranks.

A question nagged at the back of Timothy's mind. *Why are they called Dark Ones if they seem to use light and dark in equal measure in their culture? I assumed based on*

the name they would be creatures of shadow or something, but it seems I was wrong. Maybe it's symbolic of something... or maybe they just picked the name because they thought it sounded cool?

Timothy wasn't sure, but if he asked the question, he'd definitely give himself away. So, he decided not to.

The hallways were filled with all sorts of prominent Dark Ones. Timothy discreetly scanned them with his Eye, but found they were not at the level of the Emissary. Thus, they were lower than her in the social caste. Everyone bowed to varying degrees when she passed. It was clear that deference to the Emissary was an integral part of the Dark Ones' culture.

After traveling down into what Timothy felt was the roots of the tree for ten minutes, they finally arrived before a marble and granite door, the left side pitch black, and the right side bright white. An etching made of gold was drawn across both doors, in the same manner as all the buildings outside.

There was a depiction of a massive bipedal tentacled creature on the doors, a supreme being who seemed to be rising out of the ocean, reaching a claw toward the horizon to snatch the sun from the sky. His wings spread out, ready to take him to the sky where he would complete his quest to devour the light that gave his world life.

The figure was etched with exquisite detail, such that even though he was drawn in gold, Timothy got the impression the monstrous creature once had eyes as blue as the ocean he rose from.

When they arrived at the door, Sylphid turned to look at Timothy. Her gaze was pointed, as if expecting something from him. The problem was, Timothy had no idea what she wanted.

A long several seconds followed.

"You're... not going to pay respects?" Sylphid asked.

"P-pay respects?" Timothy asked, clueless.

"Yes." She said, her faint smile slowly turning to a frown. "Surely you recognize the visage of the First Darkness?"

"The First Darkness..." Timothy said slowly, trying not to panic. He carefully gave a quick look at the creature, but his thoughts were completely blank. "Uh... I apologize. I

was not... informed... of his greatness..."

Sylphid looked at him with a new gaze, as if realizing she was standing next to an idiot for the first time. "You jest with me! All Dark Ones, no matter their galaxy of birth, are to be raised properly and know of the First Darkness! It was his majesty that created our Rulers five thousand Eternities in the past and allowed us to continue existing long after our countless rivals fell!"

She paused before adding, "You cannot tell me that you don't recognize Lord Cthulhu's graven image?!"

Timothy blanched. His skin turned a sickly pallid white. "I... ah... Cthulhu is...?"

Before he could get the words out, the door to the chamber began to open inward with loud, almost violent scraping noises.

From within the chamber, a powerful voice boomed outward.

"**Thief. You have taken something which does not belong to you. YOU ARE NOT ONE OF MINE.**"

Timothy realized the situation had suddenly turned bad. Before he could make the slightest motion to reach for his Inventory, Sylphid moved forward at blinding speeds, grabbed him by the throat, and dragged him into the sacred chamber. She slammed him onto his back in the center of the chamber, and a malevolent look of glee spread across her face.

"Thief, Timothy, of the HYUU-MANS! Did you *really* think your pathetic deception would fool ME?! I've been probing you from the moment we met! Now that I have you, I will take back the Shard of Yredelemnul, which you STOLE from my people! All of your secrets will become mine!!"

Timothy's heart nearly stopped from fear. He was pinned against the ground by just Sylphid's hand, but a suppressive force bound him and froze his body in place.

He couldn't move. He couldn't even twitch his fingers, let alone activate his Inventory or use his T-REX to call to the others for help. And even if they could, how could they possibly get to him?! He was isolated in an unknown underground area.

"Sylphid, no!" Timothy screamed.

Her betrayal had come too quickly. He was not prepared in the slightest.

Part 751: Sylphid's Betrayal

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy trembled with fear as he realized he was well and truly alone. He had no way to contact his friends. He was pinned down by an enemy who would likely kill him after she'd taken what she wanted.

The only option he had left was to talk his way out of this, but how could he do that when his mind was in complete disarray?! It was like a stampede of panic-bison were storming through his mind, shutting out all rational thoughts.

"Sylphid, don't do this! I am an Emissary!!" Timothy screamed. "You're making a huge mistake!!"

Unfortunately, even if his words were completely true, he had completely lost any appearance of an Emissary's demeanor. He looked more like a panicking child to the powerful woman who dutifully maintained a tight grip on his throat.

"Hahaha! You're still speaking those tired lines!" Sylphid cackled. "All the while, trembling and pissing yourself like the vermin you are! I knew from the very beginning you were a thief from the Milky Way! Did you think our intelligence was so weak we couldn't recognize *Psions?!* We've been planning an invasion of the Milky Way for eons! Of course we would know what the Milky Way's dominant species looked like!"

She sneered, looking down at Timothy with disdain. "I don't know how you were able to steal the power of Yredelemnul, but I'll find out soon once I extract your memories, your soul, and eventually the Ruler's shard itself..."

Saying this, Sylphid's eyes began to glow. She was very careful to maintain her grip on Timothy's throat, pinning him to the ground while using her other hand to motion toward a statue on the opposite side of the room. The statue was a graven image of Cthulhu, something that seemed to possess a tiny speck of power originating from the Ruler himself.

Magical energy surged from the statue into Sylphid's left hand. Then, she lowered her palm toward Timothy's forehead.

Suddenly, a flash of Timothy's life played out in his mind. He remembered a time when he was a child and he accidentally broke one of his mother's tools. He was so scared of getting caught that he hid the tool from her, but she found it eventually, as mothers do. She admonished him at the time, telling him that lying was wrong, and he burst into tears...

The memory surfaced, then it faded. Timothy realized with a start that Sylphid was already starting to extract his memories. She would learn all of his secrets, who he was, who his mother and father were... all of it! Everything!

He had to stop her!

For a brief moment, Timothy's panic gave way to desperation. His thoughts intensified more than they ever had in the entirety of his life preceding this moment.

In that moment of desperation, Timothy remembered something.

The King Network responded to his mental intent! He had to insert and extract items from his inventory using his hands, and he also had to do a few other things with his hands, but most of the functions operated by voice, or by thought.

He could still tap into his System to find the tiniest glimmer of hope in this moment of dire need.

That was when Timothy remembered another important detail.

She's trying to read my mind. But I have a way to block her!!

Timothy immediately called up his skill list, then activated one of them with a single thought.

Mind of Void, activate!

It was the best skill he could think of using in this situation.

* * *

Mind of Void

Immunity to telepathic intrusion. Telepathic attacks reflected back at attacker at 110% damage. Distracting thoughts can be silenced for thirty minute intervals at the cost of 0.9 MP/Min. Personality altered to PSIOPHOBIC.

* * *

All of a sudden, the way Timothy's thoughts manifested themselves began to change. His viewpoint on certain parts of the world shifted. He looked at Sylphid with an expression of pure disgust.

"Trying to read my thoughts, you hideous *telepath*? NEVER!"

Sylphid's eyes widened. She screamed as an unknown power suddenly erupted in Timothy's mind, traced backward through her telepathic attack, and slammed into her psyche like a hammer against an anvil.

Ashenzari's 32nd Emissary was sent flying backward, violently thrown from Timothy's body as if an orc had uppercut her chin. She hurtled partway out of the secret chamber and crashed onto her back, coughing out a huge mouthful of blood. The full power of the telepathic attack she had planned to unleash on Timothy had instead been reflected at her, with extra power to spare!

Timothy had no time to waste. He tried to get up, but the power that was pinning him to the ground seemed to come from the statue, not Sylphid herself. However, with Sylphid's grip no longer on Timothy's throat, the statue seemed to lose its channelled effectiveness. Timothy felt the force holding him down weakening, little by little.

Sylphid coughed multiple times. Timothy's surprise attack had rattled her mind and momentarily crippled her thoughts. She was like an average human who had looked directly at a flashbang grenade right as it went off. Her proprioception was thrown off, and her eyes couldn't focus. The world spun and twisted around her in a blur.

"Yuuhh... you..." Sylphid coughed, another mouthful of blood spewing from her lips.

Timothy grunted and groaned. He tried to push himself into a sitting position, but the force holding him down was still a little too strong. With this in mind, he used the Active Ability of his Mind of Void, causing all his distracting thoughts to vanish into the wind. At the same time, he used another active skill, Player's Fixation.

* * *

Player's Fixation

The Player can focus their mind for an extended period of time, increasing learning rate and speed for a specific task by up to 500%, depending on the Player's emotional investment and mental interest in the task. High investment and interest will result in a higher payoff.

Lower values will thus lead to a lower return. The player will be locked in this state for up to twelve hours or until the task is finished, whichever is the lesser time value. The Player will need to fully sleep back to maximum mental focus and then wait 24 hours before this skill can be activated again.

* * *

The skill seemed to be intended for researching and low stakes mental improvement, but Timothy had found during his training that it had another purpose, which was that when activated, it could be pointed at most short term tasks and it would remain effective until the task or goal was completed, or for twelve hours in total, whichever was shorter.

Thus, he chose to focus on the single goal of 'I must think of a way to escape this situation alive.'

Timothy activated Player's Fixation and Mind of Void's active ability simultaneously to try and think of a way out of this predicament. The results were as he'd practiced during his grueling two months of training with Blinker.

Abruptly, all at once, Timothy's fears, his worries, his misgivings and regrets, they all vanished at the same time. Timothy's thoughts became cold and precise, similar to when he adopted the Mind of Logic.

However, there was a difference. Timothy did not change his personality, so to say. He was the same as before, but more tuned in, less distracted. He didn't feel any of his usual desires or urges, but he didn't disregard them either. He still had emotions, and those emotions could become much more concentrated compared to his default state, and in direct contrast with the Mind of Logic, which removed emotions entirely.

He became capable of focusing one hundred percent of his attention on the situation at hand.

Analysis: I have 11 level-up rewards I can use to potentially break out of this situation, including leveling a pair of skills at a time. However, one of the level-ups did not offer me a pair of skill levels, so I can only level up two skills 10 times.

Conjecture: Even if I break free of my bonds and make it past Sylphid, I will likely perish after exiting the chamber. There are too many powerful elites in the city, and potentially other Emissaries as well.

Analysis: Combat will not win the day. I must use the power of my mind at 100% efficiency.

Analysis: The power of Yredelemnul can potentially be used to escape the situation.

Timothy's eyes jumped from right to left. He looked at the room. He looked at the statue. He looked at various alien relics placed on a table to his left, and several ancient scrolls on his right.

Nothing here would provide him a weapon or armor capable of breaking out.

Plan: First, I must level up Yredelemnul's Eye. Then, I must level up another skill with the power to help me escape.

Crocodile Form? No. I am too inexperienced with it.

Divine Blaze? It is my only combat skill. It will do.

Timothy could improve two skills on most level-ups. He could not improve the same skill twice. Thus, he didn't hesitate to start rapidly powering up Yredelemnul's Eye and Divine Blaze in unison. He didn't need his hands to do this, only his thoughts. The process moved as swiftly as his speed of thought.

You have improved the Eye of Yredelemnul. Now Level 6.

You have improved Divine Blaze. Now Level 2.

You have improved the Eye of Yredelemnul. Now Level 7.

You have improved Divine Blaze. Now Level 3.

You have improved the Eye of Yredelemnul. Now Level 8.

You have improved Divine Blaze. Now Level 4.

You have improved the Eye of Yredelemnul. Now Level 9.

You have improved Divine Blaze. Now Level 5.

You have improved the Eye of Yredelemnul. Now Level 10.

You have improved Divine Blaze. Now Level 6.

Alert! The skill 'Eye of Yredelemnul' has reached MAX Level. It can no longer be improved any further.

* * *

Timothy looked with momentary astonishment at the skills he had just improved.

* * *

Eye of Yredelemnul L10 (MAX) [Active Skill] [Unique] [MP Cost 0] [AP Cost 0] [Cooldown 0]

The stolen power of a dark god courses through the Player. The Player can examine objects and entities with the Eye of Yredelemnul to learn more information about them. As the Player strengthens, the information available to them will improve drastically.

Improved+: The Eye can now see the full stats of nearly all other entities.

Improved: The Eye can sense the auras of powerful life forms.

Improved+: The Eye can better see the details of items than before.

Improved: The Eye can peer into unsealed files and perceive their full contents instantly.

Improved+: The Eye can now be used to peer through up to 100m of solid matter.

Improved: The Eye can now be used to subdue Sentient lifeforms with minds weaker than the Player.

Improved: The Eye can now be used to unleash a sight-based attack. The damage of the attack is proportional to the amount of mana spent, the Player's stat totals, and the Player's state of mind.

*Max level achieved: The Eye of Yredelemnul's final two improvements have been split into their own sub-skills, [**Yredelemnul's Disdain**] and [**Yredelemnul's Rage**]. They can be leveled on their own to obtain additional, stronger effects. The power of a Dark One grows stronger within you.*

Divine Blaze L6 [Active Skill] [Rare] [Enchantment] [Mana Cost 0.5/min (Sustained)] [Cooldown 0]

Enables the Player to temporarily enchant a melee weapon with a light and flame effect that deals a base 200% additional damage to most enemies, and up to 1000% extra damage against enemies weak to Fire or Divine attacks. Enemies resistant to both effects will take reduced damage. Remains active on the enchanted weapon until deactivated or until mana is depleted.

Improved: Your weapon now has a chance to Blind enemies when swung. This can also affect allies, so use with caution.

Improved: This weapon has a high chance to Smite undead enemies, killing them instantly. If the skill fails to Smite an undead, Smite will be unable to activate on that enemy ever again.

* * *

In addition to the two skills he had leveled up, Timothy obtained two brand new skills directly from Yredelemnul's Eye, once it reached level 10 and maxed out.

* * *

Yredelemnul's Disdain [Active Skill] [Unique] [MP Cost 25 or AP Cost 4] [Cooldown 20 seconds]

You have begun to tap more deeply into the powers of a fallen Ruler. You can now dominate the minds of other Sentients and scare them into fleeing, surrendering, or even devoting themselves to you. A failed activation of this ability may have no effect on a Sentient, or it may embolden them, making them much more hostile toward you.

This skill is most effective on Sentients far weaker than you. It dramatically loses effectiveness the more powerful a Sentient is.

Yredelemnul's Rage [Active Skill] [Unique] [MP Cost 30 or AP Cost 5] [Cooldown 20 Seconds]

You have begun to tap more deeply into the powers of a fallen Ruler. You can now unleash a sight-based attack that strikes with concussive force. This skill's power is heavily based on the Player's stats, particularly the strength of their mind, their INT, their WIS, and their accumulated knowledge.

*This skill can hurt an enemy as if the Player punched them, or it can strike with the force of a cannon, and it can hit even harder than that under certain circumstances. Players with weak minds will be unable to tap into the full power of [**Yredelemnul's Rage**].*

* * *

If this were any other time, Timothy might have been shocked senseless and leaped for joy at the upgrade he had just obtained. However, he was still in great danger. He did not have the time or the energy to feel any emotions during this imminent crisis.

I still have 5 more skill levels I can divvy out. Timothy observed. *These two new skills may just give me an opportunity to escape my predicament.*

He didn't hesitate. Timothy immediately dumped all 5 of his remaining levels into Yredelemnul's Disdain and Yredelemnul's Rage.

* * *

You have improved Yredelemnul's Disdain. Now Level 2.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Rage. Now Level 2.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Disdain. Now Level 3.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Rage. Now Level 3.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Disdain. Now Level 4.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Rage. Now Level 4.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Disdain. Now Level 5.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Rage. Now Level 5.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Disdain. Now Level 6.

You have improved Yredelemnul's Rage. Now Level 6.

* * *

With this, he improved both of his new skills to Level 6, and this empowered them beyond his greatest expectations.

* * *

Yredelemnul's Disdain [Active Skill] [Unique] [MP Cost 10 or AP Cost 1] [Cooldown 5 seconds]

You have begun to tap more deeply into the powers of a fallen Ruler. You can now dominate the minds of other Sentients and scare them into fleeing, surrendering, or even devoting themselves to you. A failed activation of this ability may have no effect on a Sentient, or it may embolden them, making them much more hostile toward you.

This skill is effective on Sentients ***somewhat stronger*** *than you. It dramatically loses effectiveness the more powerful a Sentient is beyond that threshold.*

Improved: Failed activations of this skill can now confuse Sentients.

Improved: Failed activations of this skill are more likely to cause a temporary mental suppression effect on the target.

Improved: Successful activations of this skill are more likely to cause a Sentient to revere or worship you.

Yredelemnul's Rage [Active Skill] [Unique] [MP Cost 15 or AP Cost 2] [Cooldown 5 Seconds]

You have begun to tap more deeply into the powers of a fallen Ruler. You can now unleash a sight-based attack that strikes with concussive force. This skill's power is heavily based on the Player's stats, particularly the strength of their mind, their INT, their WIS, and their accumulated knowledge.

*This skill can hurt an enemy as if the Player punched them, or it can strike with the force of a cannon, and it can hit even harder than that under certain circumstances. Players with weak minds will be unable to tap into the full power of [**Yredelemnul's Rage**].*

Improved: The Player can imbue this attack with the elements of fire or ice if they wish.

Improved: The Player can imbue this attack with the elements of dark or light if they wish.

Improved: This skill is much more likely to cause status ailments to enemies it strikes based on the imbued element, such as Burn or Freeze.

Improved: For 1 mana/second, the Player can channel the attack, ramping up its effectiveness over time.

* * *

With this, the only other options Timothy had remaining were the lootboxes and other rewards he'd earned on leveling up, but he had no time to open them, consider the options, and rationally choose the best items or skills. His current situation was dire, and he had to make a move quickly!

The good news was, after activating Player's Fixation, Timothy had sped up the thoughts in his brain by a factor of five. As long as he was 'solving a problem', which in this case was 'escaping the Golden Grove alive', the power of the skill would enhance his thinking power. But once he left the situation, his thoughts would revert back to normal, and he would even experience a decline due to exhaustion.

Thus, he had to make every second count.

Timothy thrashed around from side to side. He finally managed to push himself into a sitting position, the energy binding him feeling something like an invisible spiderweb pinning him down. But with each movement, the power of Cthulhu's statue weakened more and more. Timothy finally stood, breaking out of his quagmire.

And not a moment too soon. Sylphid also shakily stood up, her eyes bloodshot. It was clear she'd suffered a terrible blow from the reversal of her psychic attack.

"You... can... wield his power?" Sylphid coughed. "You really... inherited it?"

Timothy's eyes narrowed to slits. This bitch had betrayed him. All her cutesy antics earlier were nothing more than a ploy to get closer and isolate him from his friends. If he hadn't acted quickly, she might have turned him into a vegetable. In fact, she still might!

He had a 99% likelihood of death in the next few minutes even if he killed her, because there were still countless powerful soldiers in the vicinity.

Timothy slapped the T-REX on his chest, causing his pitch-black Spectre armor to engulf his body. At the same time, he thrust his hand into his inventory and whipped out his Longsword, the only weapon useful in this situation. A gun was probably more dangerous, but he couldn't imbue it with Divine Blaze, and the noise of a gun would draw other enemies like moths to a flame.

"You're gonna pay, you bitch." Timothy hissed. "Mind-raping scum like you deserve to DIE."

Timothy's rage boiled as he met the gaze of the Emissary. He'd never felt so enraged in all his life as he felt right now.

Just as Timothy was about to activate Divine Blaze and cut her down, a masculine voice spoke from behind Sylphid, outside the chamber beyond Timothy's view.

"Well well, Sylphid. You failed, as I thought you would. Useless, as always."

Timothy's heart dropped. A figure wearing a golden mask strolled into view. He was tall and slender; Timothy recognized him as the Emissary that had been out in the forest when Timothy met his gaze a few days before.

"It's you?" Timothy asked, stunned.

Timothy shivered. Killing Sylphid and escaping had a slim chance of success. She was injured, weakened. But this new Emissary had a much more powerful presence than her. He wasn't hurt, and his guard was up.

"Emissary Faceless!" Sylphid coughed, turning on her heel to look at the gold-masked man with a mixture of fear and anger. "When did you return?!"

"Long enough ago that I was able to witness the sight of your body sent flying. It seems your 'prey' had more bite than you expected? And now you've ended up in such a pitiful position... shouldn't you be on your knees, thanking me for saving your life? Another minute and you'd have died to this fellow's primitive weapon. What a pitiful end for an Emissary that would be."

Whoever 'Faceless' was, it was clear he wasn't an Emissary on the same level as Sylphid, but one ranked considerably higher than her. Timothy wasn't certain if Faceless was Sylphid's superior, like a commanding officer, or something similar, but it did seem the two of them had an internal conflict.

Perhaps they were semi-equals in named position, but Faceless and Sylphid were competing for rewards from a superior even higher up than them? Timothy didn't have enough information to make a determination.

"I have the situation under control!" Sylphid snapped. "Stay out of my business!"

"Oh, but it isn't 'your' business anymore." Faceless said smoothly. "This was your last chance, remember? You've disappointed Ashenzari for the last time. By the end of the day, your Blessing will be revoked. You are an Emissary no longer."

Timothy couldn't see Faceless's expression beneath the mask, but the sound of a smile was unmistakable in his voice. He was clearly *very* pleased about what had happened.

Sylphid's face turned a sickly gray. She fell to her knees and started to shake. "No... no, that's a lie... Lord Ashenzari wouldn't abandon me! I've been devoted to him my whole life!"

"Think what you like." Faceless said. "Now, while you sit there like a good girl, I will take care of this pest myself."

Faceless's head turned to look at Timothy. His blood-red eyes were barely visible through the holes in his mask.

"Are you going to struggle now, little hyuu-man?" Faceless taunted. "There won't be any point, but it will add a hint of spice to your final momen-"

A scorching red beam of energy suddenly fired from Timothy's eyes.

ZOT!!!

It crashed against Faceless's chest with the impact of a tank cannon firing at point-blank range. The masked Emissary's body went flying backward in a U-shape. He slammed into the wall hard enough to send fragments of granite and stone flying in all directions.

The corners of Timothy's mouth curled up, ever so slightly.

"Yes. I think I *will* struggle a little." Timothy answered.

Timothy stepped forward. He directed a withering glare at Sylphid. Her expression was dazed, as she had just lost something precious to her. If Faceless spoke the truth, then regardless of whether she captured Timothy or not, she had lost the support of her Ruler.

But what was strange was, when she looked at Timothy, her eyes didn't seem particularly hostile. She should have the same look as earlier, wanting him dead, but instead, it seemed almost as if...

"You truly do wield his power..." Sylphid mumbled. "I was wrong.. I was wrong! Yredelemnul's Heir, forgive me!"

Sylphid fell forward and prostrated herself at Timothy's feet, making invisible question marks pop up above his head. He hadn't expected this turn of events.

"What?" Timothy asked. His gaze shifted from Sylphid bowing at his feet to Faceless, who had collapsed to the ground from Timothy's flame-beam. Already, Faceless was recovering, and his injuries were far lighter than Slyphid's from earlier.

"You... bastard." Faceless hissed, rising to his feet. He gracefully pulled a long, wave-shaped ceremonial knife from his waistband and glowered at Timothy with rage-filled eyes. "A sneak attack. Despicable! I will take back Yredelemnul's power from you, no matter the cost!"

"Wait!" Sylphid exclaimed, lifting her head to look at Faceless. "You can't! You mustn't! He is the legitimate heir of Yredelemnul! We have no right to touch him-"

"Speak less, traitor." Faceless spat. "There are only two witnesses to this usurper's powers. After I kill you both and take Yredelemnul's shard for myself, nobody else shall know!"

Faceless lunged toward Timothy, and Timothy reflexively activated Yredelemnul's Rage once again, firing another wall-busting blast of the fire element at Faceless's

advancing figure.

Faceless was prepared this time. His rush forward was merely a feint to draw out Timothy's attack, and he instantly side-stepped, causing the laser to pound into the wall behind him. The chamber shook, but Faceless was unhurt.

He charged toward Timothy and slashed the knife down.

Riiiip!!

The blade tore through the T-REX and cut a huge diagonal gash across Timothy's body, from his top right shoulder down to the bottom left of his waist. Timothy tried to deflect the attack with his Longsword, but Faceless's speed was above the level of even a Demon Emperor. If he hadn't held back the power of his attack, he would have cut Timothy's body in half and killed him on the spot!

"Ugh..." Timothy coughed as he fell backward, landing on the ground in a heap.

Faceless sneered beneath his mask. It only took one move, and the hyuu-man was defeated. His armor was sealing up the gap with its spare nanites, but blood was pouring copiously from the wound anyway. Timothy would soon be dead, so Faceless would have to move fast to extract Yredelemnul's power from him.

But first, there was another matter to attend...

"Stop!!" Sylphid cried, a moment too late. She jumped to her feet, having mostly recovered from the mental attack earlier. Her expression was grim as Faceless turned to meet her gaze. "You can't do this! He's a true heir of the Dark Ones! His status is higher than yours!"

"You always were an eyesore." Faceless said with venomous intent. He raised his dagger, and Sylphid belatedly realized she didn't have a weapon, only her bare hands. "You are Ashenzari's Emissary no longer. Even better, I have proof you're a traitor to my god. That means I can *dispose* of you."

Faceless started to swing his blade down. But at that moment, something struck him from the side.

ZOT!!!

A laser made of ice-imbued energy crashed into Faceless for the second time and bashed him against the wall with even more force than before. Sylphid's eyes widened. She turned her head to see Timothy pushing himself up, looking completely unhurt.

"L-Lord Timothy?!" Sylphid exclaimed in bewilderment. "But you... he...?"

"Nothing a little Full Restore can't fix." Timothy chuckled.

Sylphid bobbed her head. "Yes, yes of course! How can the greatness of Yredelemnul be understood by the likes of me? Lord, I will serve you until my dying breath! Forgive me for going against your holiness earlier."

She bowed her head, looking down at Faceless's shuddering body with a renewed sense of disbelief. It seemed Timothy was far, far stronger than she had ever realized before.

Timothy walked over to Sylphid. He frowned. "You will pledge to serve me?"

"Yes!" Sylphid immediately replied. "But we must hurry, Lord Timothy! The sounds of fighting will draw guards upon us momentarily. We haven't much time."

Timothy thought for a brief moment. He realized leaving here on his own would be nearly impossible, but with Sylphid at his side...

Unfortunately, Faceless's body was simply too durable. He started to climb to his feet again, and it was clear that he had been slowed down by the frost energy pervading his body, but he was still fully capable of killing Timothy once he snapped out of his daze.

Timothy looked at Sylphid once again.

"Then serve me well, Sylphid. I'll be relying on you. Before we leave, let me handle this bug."

Timothy directed one last look at Faceless. Faceless lifted his head to glare at Timothy, having been humiliated for a second time in less than a minute.

"You... will PAY!" Faceless roared.

He started to jump at Timothy, but Timothy's eyes flashed a dark purple color beneath his T-REX.

"**INSOLENT.**" Timothy's voice boomed in Faceless's head.

Timothy activated the power of Yredelemnul's Disdain. A focused psychic attack crashed into Faceless's mind, and his pupils shrunk to pinpricks. At once, Faceless threw himself backward and plastered himself against the wall, looking at Timothy with eyes full of horror.

[**Yredelemnul's Disdain** has activated. The target has failed to resist. The Fear effect will be applied.]

[Due to the target's momentary weakness of mind, the Fear effect has been upgraded to Terror. The target will be unable to move for a short duration.]

Timothy grinned. He activated Divine Blaze, then raised his Longsword above his head, holding it with both hands.

Timothy slashed down at Faceless, intending to kill him on the spot. At the same time, Timothy made sure to keep an eye on Sylphid, lest it turn out her about-face was a distraction. What if she still planned to kill him? He couldn't let his guard down around her. *Once bitten, twice shy*, as the saying went.

But Sylphid didn't betray him. It was as if Timothy's every move were the actions of a god. Her gaze toward him had already become solemn, and it seemed she was on the path to becoming reverential.

The Longsword crashed against Faceless's body with nearly all of Timothy's strength. But then...

Snap!

The blade broke in half when it impacted Faceless's shoulder, the pointy part flying off to the side. Timothy had intended to cut Faceless in half the same way Faceless slashed him, but Timothy's damned sword broke when it made contact with Faceless's skin.

Timothy's eyes nearly popped out of his head. He was so shocked he forgot to breath for a few seconds.

"Oh... shit!"

He couldn't kill Faceless. The Emissary was too powerful! He had a body on par with Bael, which really showed how powerful Yredelemnul's Rage was to send him flying twice.

"He has been blessed by Ashenzari, my liege!" Sylphid explained. "Ordinary weapons cannot kill him. Hurry, we must go before the guards arrive!"

She shook Timothy out of his stupor. With her reminder, Timothy finally turned and ran out of the room, Sylphid leading the way.

Meanwhile, Faceless remained on the ground, shivering and shaking as he plastered himself against the wall.

"For...give...me...for...give...me..." Faceless muttered, over and over again.

Timothy had escaped immediate death, but his life was still in great danger...

Part 752: Escape!

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy and Sylphid hurried out of the inner chamber, but just before they made it to the main entrance of the Ancestor Tree, Timothy slowed his pace, causing Sylphid to stumble slightly.

"What are you doing?" Sylphid asked. "We have to move quickly."

"Only one person knows you are no longer an Emissary of Ashenzari." Timothy said, his mind still revolving quickly as thoughts rapidly filled up his brain. "We can use this chance to foment confusion. I want you to find some guards and tell them Faceless has betrayed Ashenzari and tried to kill you."

Sylphid looked at Timothy as if he were an imbecile. "Who would believe such a claim? I'll be found out within minutes! Faceless is much higher ranked than me!"

"You will, but every minute matters. If we spin the narrative first, we'll have more leeway to work with."

Faceless was surely going to recover from the Terror status Timothy had inflicted on him. He could get up and start chasing them any second now. Every minute they could gain was another minute they could use to escape.

Sylphid was a powerful warrior, but her thoughts were actually quite simple. She had lived a life of luxury and privilege, and was not familiar with guerilla tactics. On the other hand, Timothy had gone through a couple of months of intensive training with Blinker. It wasn't much, but that small bit of knowledge was being thoroughly used well in his special mental-state.

His thinking speed was accelerated fivefold, so he had time to come up with plans and counter-measures he normally wouldn't.

Thus, Sylphid had no choice but to go along with her new master's wishes. Even though she looked somewhat miserable, with bloodshot eyes and a battered body, Sylphid quickly reverted to her usual demeanor.

She strode out into the main aisle and assumed a domineering personality.

"Emissary Faceless has betrayed Ashenzari!" Sylphid shouted, taking a bold and uncompromising stance. "I have received word from Ashanzari himself. We are to hunt down and kill Faceless without delay! Call the Seven Water Lords and tell them to meet me in the Justice Hall. The rest of you, wait here for Faceless the Fallen to emerge from the room behind me. Capture him and take him to a holding cell."

Sylphid's declaration was so surprising and unusual that for a brief moment, the five guards that had just shown up were a little unsure of what to do.

Thus, Sylphid hardened her gaze and glowered at them. "On the double!"

Seeing that she was injured and had clearly fought a terrible battle against the 'traitor', four of the guards rushed into the room to subdue Faceless, while the last guard left to alert the Seven Water Lords, whoever they might be.

The moment the guards were out of sight, and earshot, Timothy hissed into Sylphid's ear, "Good work. Now let's get the hell out of here!"

They power-walked out of the Ancestor Tree, leaving behind a mess of disorganized and confused guards in their wake.

* * *

At the same time, inside Cthulhu's Secret Chamber, Faceless finally broke free of his state of Terror. His body continued to shake with fear, and though he knew his emotions were irrational, he discovered that he couldn't immediately recover from the mental damage he had suffered. Whatever that hyuu-man had done, it had severely injured his psyche.

"Bastard!" Faceless roared. He started to move to the exit, only for four guards to rush inside, pointing their spears at him.

"Emissary Faceless! For crimes against Ashenzari, we must place you under arrest! Please come with us willingly and do not resist!"

Faceless's rage momentarily vanished. He was startled by this development. "What... what are you imbeciles doing?! I am the last of Ashenzari's Emissaries in the Golden Grove! Did Sylphid put you up to this? She has been expelled from Ashenzari's Order! She is an Emissary no longer!"

The guards were not moved. They had received their orders, and judging by the ragged state Faceless seemed to be in, it was clear he and Sylphid had fought a terrible battle,

with her coming out on top. Everyone knew Faceless was mightier than Sylphid, but now it seemed Sylphid had been hiding her power.

With this, the four guards knew what they had to do. They attacked Faceless together, striking multiple painful blows on his body, while Faceless fought back, quickly defeating all of them. Deep cuts and gashes were cut across Faceless's chest and arms, but he successfully killed the rebellious guards after a few minutes.

"Kah, pah!!" Faceless coughed, spitting blood in a fine spray. "Sylphid, I underestimated you! Good, very good! I won't let you get away, no matter what it takes!"

He stormed out of Cthulhu's Chamber, clutching his wounds as his hatred for the traitor climbed further toward its peak.

* * *

Once Timothy and Sylphid made their way out of the Ancestor Tree, they were able to travel much more quickly. It turned out Sylphid had the ability to fly through a unique form of telekinesis that was different from what the Psions used, but in a way Timothy couldn't really explain. She picked up Timothy, and the two of them raced back to where Timothy's friends were situated.

Timothy turned on his T-REX and spoke through it, informing the others of the situation. By the time they arrived, the group was armored up and ready to go.

"We're leaving?" Paimon asked, looking at Sylphid with suspicion from behind his helmet. "And you betrayed your people?"

"No time to talk!" Timothy shouted. "Let's get out of the city before it's too late. We'll chit-chat once we're safe!"

The group didn't have time to waste. Faceless could be on their ass in seconds, and the worst situation would have their group surrounded and captured... or even killed.

The Psions grabbed onto the other three, while Sylphid used her unique means to fly alongside them. All six took to the skies and raced away, with Sylphid explaining to the outer guards that she'd been given a 'secret mission' by Ashenzari and would be heading south. She made it clear that it was none of their business, and she had no need to explain herself.

After they left, the group did not fly south. They flew east first, then turned to head north. Sylphid's words were another minor trick Timothy thought up to get them out of

the situation.

However, not long after leaving the city, a problem cropped up. Timothy's brain slowed back down to its normal state, and at the same time, he experienced a severe mental crash. Having achieved the goal he had set, Timothy's 'Player Fixation' skill had reached its conclusion and turned off, subjecting him not only to his ordinary brain speed, but a temporary 'depleted' state that made his thoughts more sluggish and tired than usual.

As such, the life seemed to drain from Timothy's eyes. He hung in the middle of the formation, exhausted beyond reason, while Marigold viciously grilled Sylphid.

"You bitch!" Marigold shrieked. "You tried to kill my Timmy, and now you think you can just join us?! Why don't you piss off and die, huh?"

"I was at fault, and I am truly sorry." Sylphid said. "I had eyes but could not see Lord Timothy's greatness. My god has already denounced me, so I shall serve Lord Timothy as my new master. Someday, I hope to see his ascension into a proper Dark One."

Her words, though apologetic, did not make Marigold feel any better. Steam practically hissed out of Marigold's ears.

"S-serve him?!" Marigold snapped. "You sneaky hussy, don't think I can't see what you're doing right now! Timothy, Timmy, say something! Tell this betraying, backstabbing bitch she needs to leave!!"

Timothy's eyes were glazed over. His head wobbled from side to side due to the backlash of Player's Fixation.

"Uhhh... huh?" Timothy mumbled. "What... you said?"

"I said- I said... never mind! We'll worry about the details later!" Marigold said, shooting a vicious glare Sylphid's way. She hurriedly levitated to Timothy's side to hold and comfort him. "Are you okay, Timmy? Do you need something?"

"I'm tired..." Timothy said, barely keeping his eyes open. "Eyes so heavy... can't keep... them open..."

The group was not out of danger. Faceless would likely resolve the temporary confusion Sylphid had created, then send out search squads to hunt Timothy and the others down.

But Timothy could not be counted on any longer. His mental state was at its weakest, and the others had to treat him like an NPC in need of protection. As such, Marigold pressed her jaw together and chuffed.

"Fine. Just get some sleep. We'll handle whatever comes next." Marigold said decisively.

Timothy nodded. His eyes closed a moment later, and he fell unconscious. He had pushed himself way beyond his mental limits, and now he had to deal with the repercussions of that decision.

But even so, the situation was far better now than before. Falling into a deep sleep was obviously preferable to being killed in the Secret Chamber!

After a few moments, Paimon gave Sylphid a long look.

"You, Emissary." Paimon said. "You can speak our language? Yet you pretended not to be able to do so, earlier?"

"I'm not an Emissary anymore." Sylphid said. "But yes. I could always speak it. You Milky Way denizens are painfully stupid. You blabbed your secret plans out loud *right* in front of me. You need to realize that in the Ruler's Game, your galaxy is simply meat on the chopping block. You have little knowledge of other galaxies. Your lack of a Ruler has left you vulnerable."

Towards Timothy, Sylphid was deferential and respectful. But towards the rest of his group, aside from feeling apologetic about the harm she'd caused him, it was clear at a glance she didn't give half a damn about any of the rest. Their feelings and thoughts meant nothing to her. She looked at them as weaklings. Her gaze was scornful.

Only Timothy had earned her respect.

Now that she had joined their side, there was no need to lie about the language barrier any longer. Paimon and the rest realized the Dark Ones knew far more about the Milky Way's cultures, its languages, and its species than the Milky Way's Sentients did about any other galaxy.

However, the Volgrim higher-ups were not as ignorant as Sylphid thought. The problem was, Timothy was not Unarin, and neither were any of his companions. Timothy and the others lacked millions of years of accumulated knowledge regarding the Dark Ones.

In this way, Sylphid's scorn was somewhat misplaced. She thought Timothy represented a 'ruling elite' among the Milky Way and the others were his servants, but her assumption was erroneous from the start. Timothy may have been the son of a Wordsmith, but that Wordsmith himself never fully reached the level of a ruling elite while he was alive.

Perhaps the thing that bothered Timothy's friends the most was that Sylphid simply didn't take the rest of them seriously at all. She dropped the act because it didn't matter whether they knew she was originally lying about speaking their language or not. Why would she care? What could they do to stop her? She was stronger than all of them combined, and with Faceless chasing them, they needed her power.

The group raced into the forest, levitating Timothy's comatose body as they traveled. Him being awake or not wouldn't slow them down or speed up their movement, so they made relatively good time regardless.

Now though, with Sylphid in their party, the group was able to be a bit more reckless. Other creatures recognized Sylphid and carefully shied away. An entire group of Dark Forest Stalkers spotted the group of six, but rather than pursuing them, they stealthily slinked back into the darkness.

[Sylphid.] Ferral said calmly, after three hours on the move came and went. [It is quite handy having you with us. We are able to speed up our progress drastically.]

Sylphid sneered at the young Psion. "Imbecile. Everywhere I go, the creatures of this forest fear my name. That is not a good thing today. Rumors will spread quickly. Those rumors will make their way back to Faceless. I have no doubt he's already determined our current position and is moving toward us, after interrogating the local residents."

The former Emissary returned her gaze forward. She knitted her brow in consternation.

"You lot are painfully slow. I have had to reduce my speed significantly so as to not outpace you. If Faceless catches up to us in three, no, two hours, I would not be surprised. I feel as if I am crawling out of the forest on my hands and knees."

She continued. "The Dark Forest is a place of isolation and silence. Only peak existences like myself can traverse it freely and without fear. Even so, there are other monstrosities hiding within the shadows that would see me without my assigned protectors and jump at the chance to devour me. This is a vicious land where the weak are

prey for the strong. Even as I speak, fourteen distinct gazes are fixated upon me, monitoring my movements. If you have a method to escape the Dark Forest, you had better use it soon."

Ferral was not one to express emotions outwardly, but even he felt chills go down his spine. He quickly swept his senses outward, but he couldn't detect a single creature nearby. Either Sylphid was lying to scare him, or her senses were far, far sharper than his.

Sylphid chuckled. She easily felt Ferral's crude use of Psionics to feel the world around him. "You are not a permanent resident of the Dark Forest. I do not know from which part of the Milky Way your people came from, but you are nothing more than prey to the true monsters of the Dark Forest. Naturally, you will not be able to detect those who do not wish to be seen with your crude, unrefined abilities."

Ferral's situation was similar to a young tiger trying to catch and eat a jellyfish out in the deep ocean. Tigers were powerful and frightening on land, but when placed in the deep sea, they lost nearly all of their strength and would thrash and drown in the clutches of the unfamiliar terrain.

As for Sylphid, she was a long-time resident of the Dark Forest. She knew all the 'tricks' the creatures of her realm used to hide themselves. There were a handful that could evade her senses, but they were rare exceptions to the rule, and they posed her no threat anyway.

One hour later, Sylphid's expression darkened. She glanced backward as the group flew.

"He's coming." Sylphid said. "I can sense Faceless's approach. Is this really the fastest you lot can travel?"

[It is.] Raavul answered. [If I were on my own and not carrying others, I could triple my speed. But I am not, and thus, I cannot.]

"I don't know where exactly you're planning to run or hide, but if we don't make it to your destination soon, Faceless will catch up and our demise is basically guaranteed." Sylphid said with a grimace.

Paimon's expression was no better than hers. "We don't know where we're going, either."

"What??" Sylphid gasped. "Then what is your goal?!"

"North." Paimon said. "If we can reach the edge of the forest, we can break out and escape this place. By that point, we'll be able to use our... unique means... to depart this realm."

"The edge of the forest??" Sylphid asked in bewilderment, her skin paling further. "There is no such thing! This entire world is covered by the forest! Every inch of it!"

Paimon almost lost heart at her words, but then he remembered the fact his entire party had 'entered' the forest at some point unknown. That meant Sylphid's words were wrong.

Was this world real? Was it artificial? Was it a game-like environment with special rules the 'NPCs' like Sylphid didn't know about? Or was she correct and their mission was a lost cause?

"It exists." Paimon said firmly. "We've already passed into the forest from the southern edge. If we keep moving north, we'll find that edge as well."

"The southern edge?" Sylphid asked, before shaking her head. "I know not of what you speak. Such a border does not exist. Perhaps I was wrong to follow you lot after all."

"Then you can just stay behind! Shoo, go away!" Marigold snapped, raising her middle claw to flip Sylphid off. "We don't need you anyway."

"I wouldn't be so sure about that." Sylphid replied. "Once Faceless arrives, you will learn the meaning of despair in the face of overwhelming power. In my best state, I can only match his strength when he's not fighting seriously. Once he does, I will not be his opponent, and neither will any of you. Except for Lord Timothy, of course..."

A look of reverence entered Sylphid's eyes once again. Even though her dislike of his weakling friends only grew stronger with time, Sylphid's feelings toward Timothy had not dulled in the slightest. He was exhausted and weak now, but once he recovered, she felt he alone would be able to put up a fight against Faceless.

Timothy was the group's only hope. They had to hold on long enough to let him rest. Once his mind was rejuvenated, they might stand a chance against Faceless!

"There's something you all need to be aware of." Sylphid said, her tone shakier and more nervous now that she could feel Faceless's aura slowly approaching from behind. "Ashenzari's more faithful devotees can acquire immense power by binding powerful curses to their bodies. The more they sacrifice, the more power they can receive."

She continued. "I have cursed my body several times. That is how I managed to rise to the level of an Emissary. But the most brutal curses give the greatest boosts in power. Faceless... the curse he chose was one I simply could not bring myself to accept. That is why his body is as durable as Skyforged Steel, and his energy as overflowing and bottomless as the deepest sea."

Raavul casually scanned Sylphid's body. Sylphid was an Apex Mortal, an existence above Demon Emperors, on par with Satan the Devil and other Demon Overlords. However, she was clearly at the bottom of that tier, while Faceless stood at the pinnacle. Faceless was only a step away from becoming a Bottom Cosmic, at which point he would gain the power to flatten planets.

Given this, a mere 'Mortal' like Raavul would not be able to put up the slightest struggle against such an enemy. The same could be said for the others in her party.

One more hour passed.

Altogether, five hours had passed since the group had escaped the Golden Grove. It was at this point that Timothy finally stirred.

The young Hero shook himself out of a stupor and lifted his head to look around. His eyes were bleary. His mind was still in a fugue state. He couldn't think properly, and he had yet to recover from his mental exertion.

He needed more rest, but for some reason, a fear had built up in his heart as he sensed a frightening horror approaching his body. He shook himself awake out of instinct and looked around.

"Whuh... where are we?" Timothy asked, his speech slightly slurred.

"We're on the run." Marigold quickly replied. "Kyargh! That Faceless guy is chasing us. He'll probably catch up any minute."

"Faceless..." Timothy repeated. "Faceless. He... who...?"

It took Timothy's mind a while to revolve, to understand what was going on, and to remember what had happened. Timothy eventually understood the situation, but he had no sense of urgency. He was still absolutely exhausted.

"Shit... whuhdowedo?" Timothy sleepily asked.

"I don't know." Marigold said quietly.

"We will have to do everything in our power to make sure Lord Timothy survives." Sylphid said. "Everyone. I will stay behind and try to delay Faceless. I won't be able to do much... but maybe I can pull off a miracle..."

"Inadvisable." Paimon immediately retorted. "You are the strongest member of our group. With you present, we have a small chance to come out victorious by relying on teamwork. If you fight Faceless alone, we will lose without a doubt. I believe we might be able to prevail if we work together, using our unique strengths to catch Faceless off-guard."

Timothy might be out of commission, but Paimon was considered the brains of the group anyway. He was a demon who had thousands of years of battle experience to his name. He wasn't on the level of Blinker or Kar, but he was quite formidable in his own right, and he had a keen tactical mind.

"I'm going to require some of the items your mother gave you, Timothy." Paimon said as he pulled out the incredibly powerful AR-15 he had brought along. As the pinnacle of human weapon engineering, this weapon gave him the greatest assurance he could potentially take out Faceless. "I know you're not in your best mental state, but surely using your Inventory won't tax you too much?"

Timothy slowly blinked his eyes. "Yeahhh... sure... man."

Ten more minutes passed. Paimon quickly came up with a game plan. Then, the six of them came to a stop between two giant towering trees, with a deep lake of pitch-black water some distance up ahead. Paimon and Raavul flew to the left tree, Ferral and Marigold flew to the right tree, and Sylphid remained on the ground with Timothy amidst the dense underbrush, between both trees. She stood in front of him protectively, clutching a knife Paimon had given her.

This knife was a special one. It was made of Wordsmithium, and it had the unique ability to strike multiple times when attacking someone. It was a prototype Jason had made, but it had never been used in real battle. At the very least, Paimon thought it might be durable enough to kill Faceless if Sylphid could hit him with a sneak attack.

Now that the group had come to a stop, Faceless's energy signature roared toward them at a speed beyond comprehension. Less than a minute later, the Emissary arrived, followed by more than two hundred other warriors of the Golden Glade. Sylphid paled when she saw all seven Water Lords had also come along.

The Water Lords were not as strong as the Emissaries, but their combined strength could definitely hold Sylphid up, let alone when combined with Faceless's battle strength.

Timothy's group was screwed. There was no way they could come out of this alive.

"Hahaha..." Faceless chuckled evilly as he levitated forward, the warriors behind him taking up defensive positions in the air and on the ground.

All the warriors he had brought along could fly extremely quickly, and though they were not as fast as Faceless himself, they were still High Mortals on par with Demon Emperors.

"It seems you've given up." Faceless said teasingly. He sent a slightly anxious glance Timothy's way, but it didn't take a genius to see Timothy was completely exhausted. Faceless was able to relax a little, feeling some of the mental trauma from Timothy's earlier attacks fade into the back of his mind. "Or maybe you still think you can put up some futile resistance?"

The Emissary was in somewhat bad shape. Not only had he been slapped around by Timothy's eye-beams, but he'd also ended up slightly brutalized by those four traitorous guards in his weakened state. His body was cut up and scabbed all over, making him especially gruesome to look at.

Faceless chuckled again. He lifted his head and easily spotted four other little weaklings up in the trees. It was clear Sylphid had planned an ambush of some sort. But what sort of pitiful effect could her new allies muster? They were garbage, lower than the weakest dregs of the Dark Forest.

There was no escape. There was no victory. There was only death and the future rise of Faceless once he stole the power of Yredelemnul from Timothy's cold, dead corpse.

Sylphid felt her fighting spirit weakening. The seven Water Lords shook their heads wryly. They knew the fall of the former Emissary was nigh. Her tricks had fooled them for a short while and made them doubt Faceless's words, but strength was what ruled above all in the Golden Glade, and with Sylphid fleeing the city, it didn't take much convincing from Faceless to make them realize Sylphid had duped them.

She was an Emissary no more. She was a dead woman walking.

"Any last words?" Faceless asked. "I can grant you at least this much, after all your years of 'devotion' to the god you betrayed."

Sylphid trembled. She was... afraid. Only 24 hours before, she was a lauded Emissary, someone respected and feared. Now she was nothing. None of her former prestige remained. She had made a decision that cost her everything. She did not know how she could live with her decision, and it seemed she would not be 'living' in any meaning of the word by the time the next day came around.

Sylphid opened and closed her mouth a few times. She couldn't find the strength to speak.

Then, Timothy stepped forward and rested a palm on her shoulder. Sylphid blinked.

Had he recovered? Was this the return of Yredelemnul's glory, through the avatar of his successor?!

It was obvious Timothy was reassuring her with his touch that everything would be okay. He had a plan, and he was going to reveal it now.

Timothy smiled at Faceless.

"...Maaaan, shuthefuckup bro, you're jes', fucken yappin and shit. I amsooootired right now, like I could just fallasleeplistenin' to ya."

Timothy yawned loudly, a clear provocation toward Faceless. He blinked away sleepy tears as he struggled to remain standing by holding on to Sylphid's shoulder.

"Bro ifyou'regonnakillus then just, like, fuckingdoit okay man? I ain't got timeforyourshiiiiiiit..."

Timothy yawned one more time. Then he fell forward onto his face and started snoring under the undergrowth leaves.

Faceless's right eye twitched, ever so subtly.

"...*Kill them now.*" Faceless said through gritted teeth. "But leave the *hyuu-man* to me."

Part 753: Defeated, Disgraced

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy fell forward onto his face. Still too exhausted to do any fighting, he collapsed, leaving the other five to protect him.

All hell broke loose. The seven Water Lords rushed toward Timothy and Sylphid, while the other 100 knights split in two, with 50 jumping up into the trees toward Paimon and Raavul, and the other 50 charging at Ferral and Marigold.

As for Faceless, he himself did not immediately make a move. He was badly injured not only from Timothy's attack on his mind and body, but also the four guards who he ultimately had to kill. Those four guards were elite soldiers stationed inside the Ancestor Tree, and their attack power had left him hurting.

Just because Faceless won the fight didn't mean he escaped uninjured. He wasn't Beelzebub. He didn't have a powerful healing factor. His body itself was extremely durable, but if injured, he would need a long time to fully recover.

Faceless watched as the seven Water Lords attacked Sylphid. She was, undoubtedly, the main threat he had to worry about. The other weaklings weren't worth a sneeze, but Faceless would be lying if he said he didn't also carry deep fear toward Timothy.

It was that damn hyuu-man who thrashed him thrice. Timothy had sent him flying with two eye-laser attacks and a psychic attack that left Faceless shaking in his shadow. Sylphid was only a threat now because of all the damage Timothy had done directly and indirectly. If it weren't for the hyuu-man, Faceless would be in pristine condition, his image untarnished, and Sylphid at his mercy.

The truth was, the power of an Emissary was second to their prestige, and their prestige was directly related to the air of authority they wielded. Now that Faceless had suffered such a terrible sequence of losses, and now that he looked like a dog that had been tortured by sadists, the Water Lords didn't look at him with as much fear and favor as before. By contrast, Sylphid was in much better shape. It left people wondering who was really the stronger Emissary...

Sylphid wielded the Wordsmithium knife Timothy had given her. Its reach was minuscule, and its cutting power wasn't as powerful as one might expect, but the knife was basically indestructible, despite its size.

One of the Water Lords swung a massive halberd down at Sylphid. She quickly raised the knife and caught the halberd's shaft with the knife's blade, causing a loud clanging sound to ring out. The Third Water Lord was left in disbelief that her hundred-kilo weapon had been completely stopped by a simple looking knife.

"How?!" The woman cried.

Sylphid didn't answer. The First and Second Water Lords attacked from opposite directions, forcing her to bend her body and launch powerful kicks at one of the approaching enemies. She smashed the First aside and sent him flying while dodging the Second Water Lord with her superior agility.

Water Lords were second to the Emissaries, and each one wielded power similar to a Demon Emperor. Sylphid might be a lot weaker than Faceless under normal conditions, but she was a powerful fighter on par with a Demon Overlord, and much stronger than the Water Lords. Only by coordinating together could they threaten her.

At the same time, Paimon and Raavul were working together to fight off the massive horde of powerful enemies charging at them. Fifty enemies all ranked between Demon Duke and Demon Emperor were way, way beyond anything they could handle. Raavul was only as strong as a Demon Baron at best, and Paimon was a Demon Grunt in the most literal sense.

Thus, it stood to reason they would die instantly. That was certainly what the overconfident Sequid Warriors leaping up the trees toward them thought.

The Psions could fly. So could Marigold, equipped with a Hummer T-REX, and Paimon, who had the other Hummer in his possession, as well as a Spectre in reserve. Faceless and Sylphid could fly, and so could the Water Lords, but the Elite Sequid Warriors they brought along could not! They had to climb the trees and leap around using their superior strength.

Their bodies moved agilely, smoothly, like sharks swimming vertically through the ocean toward the underside of their prey above.

Then, something curious happened. Paimon grabbed a metal cylinder off his waist, pulled a pin of some sort out, and threw it toward the densest mass of Sequid Warriors.

FSSSS!

A violent hissing sound erupted as the grenade he had just thrown burst apart, spraying sticky white-hot smoke in a massive cone downwards. It was no ordinary grenade, but a White Phosphorous Grenade that spread out in a fiery gas, adhering to flesh, metal, and wood alike. The air itself started burning the lungs of all the warriors, lighting their skin on fire, and causing their eyes to turn red from agony.

Of the fifty that were charging toward Raavul and Paimon, twenty were instantly downed, and the remaining thirty quickly retreated, visibly shocked by whatever the hell Paimon had just thrown at them.

Not ready to end the show just yet, Paimon grabbed the second grenade off his belt and threw it downward, but this time the pin popped off in midair, and the grenade started 'homing' in on the next largest group of Sequids that hadn't been hit by the previous grenade.

"No!!" One of the warriors screamed, as Raavul used her telekinesis to make the grenade explode mere inches from his face. The scream that warrior let out before he fainted from his injuries send shivers down the backs of the survivors.

At the same time, with their enemies in momentary disarray, Paimon pulled out his AR-15, one of the mightiest infantry weapons ever created by ancient humanity, and started taking potshots at any uninjured Sequids in sight.

Bullets ricocheted off armor and sunk into flesh. Though these Sequids were at least as strong as most Demon Emperors, their bodies were surprisingly vulnerable to fast-moving tiny metal projectiles. Paimon managed to dome one of the enemies in the head, which somehow didn't kill the Sequid but instead made it fall to the ground and start spasming like a snake on hot cement.

While Paimon and Raavul were dealing with their enemies, so too were Ferral and Marigold. Ferral used his telekinesis to try and push the enemies back down toward the forest floor, but his telekinesis was even weaker than Raavul's, so how could that be possible? He only managed to slow down their movements a little and occasionally throw off their jumps and grabs as they climbed toward him and Marigold.

As for Marigold, she had been feeling annoyed and restless ever since entering the Dark Forest. Even though a massive number of powerful enemies were charging at her, she felt no fear at all.

"Time to test out these new toys!!" Marigold cheered.

Marigold wore her Hummer T-REX, which granted her limited flying ability. The bright-yellow color also drew everyone's attention, making them target her once the wings on the back of the suit lit up with energy.

She leaped downward toward one of the nearest Sequids, who snorted at her with wry amusement.

"Come to rush to your death?" The Sequid taunted.

"Nope!" Marigold laughed, as she reared her fist back.

Too late, the Sequid noticed that both of her lower arms seemed to sport much thicker and heavier armor than the rest of her body. He had no time to reconcile this information as he sent a fist flying to meet hers.

BOOOOM!!!

A thunderous explosion blasted out of Marigold's fists, traveled into and through that Sequid's body, and sent him flying down at the ground nearly at the speed of sound. The Sequid crashed into the forest floor with a terrific bang. He broke all the bones in his body and died on impact, all without knowing he had even met his end. His death had come too quickly.

"What in Ashenzari's name?!" One of the other Sequids nearest Marigold exclaimed, right before she spun around and flew toward him. "No! NOOO!"

BOOOOM!!

Another terrific explosion of sound exploded against that Sequid's body and send him flying into a tree in the distance. His body exploded into meat paste on impact, leaving a horrific bloody mess in its wake.

The other Sequids recoiled in fear. They were proud warriors who had fought many battles and were not afraid of death, but the clear weakness of their 'prey' coupled with the sudden explosive power simply overturned their mental models of the world. They were scared shitless!

In truth, Marigold's power was not her own. She had taken Jason Hiro's experimental 'Thunder Gauntlets' from storage before she left, and now they were revealing their power when worn by a fine Crocodile warrior like herself.

The previously arrogant Sequids flew into disarray when faced with the power of an angry crocodile wearing armor-busting gauntlets. Many of them chose to charge at Ferral, since he seemed a lot weaker than her.

Those Sequids, as well as the ones that chose to target Raavul, made a different kind of mistake. When unencumbered by their companions, both Psions were capable of extremely quick and precise movements in the air. They possessed the power of self-telekinesis, granting them high speed and agility when flying.

Faceless and Sylphid could fly, as well as the seven Water Lords. But the Sequid Elites they had brought along could not! Thus, when they tried to attack Ferral, he simply switched to evading them, using his telekinesis to manipulate a tiny marble made of Wordsmithium as his primary method of attack.

This was something he and Raavul had found to be extremely potent. These tiny Wordsmithium Marbles were nothing crazy, literally just the remnants of Jason's experiments, but they were practically indestructible, difficult to dodge, and easy to fling around at ultra-high speeds.

Thus, the Wordsmithium marbles started acting like bullets that could bounce around, ricochet, and attack multiple enemies at once.

Ferral deftly flew left and right, up and down, evading ten different Sequids that had targeted him. He sent his marble flying with extreme precision, crashing against the knee of one Sequid Elite and causing him to scream in pain as the bone shattered on impact. The marble flew into the ear canal of another at several hundred KPH, bursting his head and spraying his brains out in a mist.

Like this, Timothy's 'weak' comrades actually put up a brutal fight against Faceless's Elite troops.

Faceless was shocked. He did not expect a tiny ragtag group of weaklings to possess such bite.

"It seems I have no choice but to directly intervene..." Faceless said quietly to himself.

With this, Faceless suddenly charged into the fray, rushing toward Sylphid right in the crucial moment the Fifth and Sixth Water Lords were pincer-attacking her. Sylphid's heart jumped. She sensed Faceless's charge, but she had to continue dodging the Water Lords, even as Faceless slapped down at her head with his bare palm.

CRACK!

Faceless struck Sylphid's face with his full strength. It was like a lightbulb had been turned off. The fire went out in Sylphid's eyes, and she was mercilessly pounded into the ground. Her body went limp, and she fainted immediately.

With this, the Seven Water Lords were suddenly free to go elsewhere. And so they did. The First through Fourth Water Lords charged up at Raavul, using their flight to come at her from all directions. Raavul's expression didn't change, but her internal organs felt a spike of panic as she was suddenly surrounded by four of the strongest enemies on the field.

Seconds later, Raavul tumbled from the sky. Her body crashed into the forest floor below, and two elite Sequids jumped on her to pin her to the dirt.

The same fate came for Ferral as the Fifth through Seventh Water Lords targeted him. With Raavul down, Ferral was the next obvious flying target. The Water Lords chased after him, beat him down, and slapped him out of the sky. Ferral crashed into the ground not far from Timothy's unconscious body. Ferral shuddered in pain, but he couldn't stand up. Two more Elite Sequids grabbed and pinned him in place.

Marigold screamed in anger. "You cheating bullies! Come at me all at once! I'll still take you down! Kyaaargh!!"

Her words were brave, but once all seven of the Water Lords arrived, they were able to outmaneuver her while avoiding her Thunder Gauntlets. With one brutal attack, they struck her head and knocked the daylight out of her, also sending her crashing to the forest floor.

Paimon was the last one. Seeing his friends fall one after the other, he knew the battle was over.

Instead of fighting for his life, Paimon did something that surprised the Sequids. He retreated into the forest while activating a Spectre T-REX he'd borrowed from Marigold.

He activated stealth mode and fled before the Water Lords could come after him, leaving them enraged.

"He won't get away!" The First Water Lord declared.

"Leave him for now." Faceless said. "One stray pest makes no difference. He's the weakest one of all."

Faceless looked at the pinned bodies before him. Sylphid was down for the count. Timothy was still out cold. Both Psions were beaten and battered, and their pitiful psionic powers were no match for the elites atop them. Even Marigold, still struggling to break free of her captors, was forced onto her belly with her arms pinned behind her back.

"Hahaha." Faceless laughed, finally feeling his heart lighten. "In the end, everything falls into my hands."

"You... you're gonna pay for this!" Marigold snarled. "You don't know who you're messing with!"

Faceless nodded and smiled. "You are correct, wetland-creature. I do not know who I'm 'messing with'. However, once I take back the stolen shard of Yredelemnul, I will also acquire the thief's memories. All shall be made clear at that point. Who you are, what your intentions are, and how you managed to sneak into my forest undetected."

Faceless folded his hands behind his back and assumed a domineering posture. He nodded at the First and Second Water Lords. "Lift him up."

Faceless turned his mask toward Timothy, watching as they grabbed the unconscious young man and lifted him up by both of his arms. They didn't take him lightly, and made sure to hold his arms tightly so he couldn't thrash around, even if he had the strength to do so.

Timothy was still wearing a T-REX, though he had traded with one of his friends earlier, and now he wore the distinct red and blue Thundercat variant. It was a little more heavily armored, but ultimately still nothing compared to the strength of the Water Lords.

Timothy's armored head hung downward. But as he was picked up, he awoke and shakily lifted his head.

"Uhh..." Timothy said weakly, his voice coming through the speakers. "What... happened..."

Faceless chuckled. "Your escape attempt failed, brat. In the end, your friends were unable to save you. But what did you expect, with such weaklings at your side? One of them even ran away, the coward. I'll be sure to have him hunted down and executed like the pest he is."

Timothy's HUD pulled up vitals for his friends. With a single thought, he was able to tell all hope had been lost. Marigold was conscious, but pinned. The Psions were in a similar state. Sylphid was out cold. Only Paimon had managed to escape.

The young man was groggy, like a drunk. His thoughts were more sluggish than ever in his life. He couldn't think of any witty plans, any brilliant maneuvers...

Timothy tried to wriggle his body, but the grip on him was too strong. The Water Lords tensed their arms, making Timothy grimace in pain. It felt like his arms were going to shatter under their grip. Even if he was in his best state, he wouldn't have had the strength to escape.

"You... fucker!" Timothy wheezed. Desperate, he activated his ultimate attack.

Yredelemnul's Rage!

A flicker of red light ignited in his eyes. A laser fired through his helmet and instantly crossed the distance between himself and Faceless, burning two holes in the T-REX's faceplate. The laser slapped against Faceless's body and made him flinch in fear, but this time... it did nothing at all. The helmet repaired itself, and Faceless was left standing there, unharmed.

Timothy's thoughts were too slow, his willpower too weak. He was drained, and thus, the prowess of Yredelemnul's skills, which heavily relied on mental energy and willpower, were rendered totally useless.

A drop of cold sweat dripped down Faceless's back, but he quickly relaxed. Even he could see that Timothy had nothing left.

"Hahaha! You startled me!" Faceless roared with laughter. "Was that it, then? The last dying gasp of a false Emissary? You should be thanking me, you know. I deliberately left your friends alive. I could have had my warriors kill them, but I suspect the intelligence we'll be able to extract from them will prove *quite* useful. I'm interested in learning how you arrived in my lands, and how you thought you could escape. It can't be a coincidence you were traveling in this direction the whole time..."

Timothy felt the strength leave his body. A sense of despair washed over him.

He activated Yredelemnul's Eye to examine Faceless. Maybe he could uncover a weakness? Something to turn the tides?

* * *

Emissary of Ashenzari - Dark Forest - Supreme Existence

A powerful adherent of the cult of Ashenzari. An elite capable of fighting ten other Sentients at the same time. Fast and strong, their lacking defense is improved by the quality of their armor. Ashenzari's Emissaries possess the power to tap into nature itself, making them especially deadly in dense woodlands.

This particular Emissary has defied the weakness of their species by cursing their body with Ashenzari's power. As a result, this entity's defenses are far higher than normal, but a significant price was paid for the benefits.

Faceless - Sequid - Emissary of Ashenzari

Level ?? | Apex Mortal

HP 112/445 (Severely Injured)

AP 112/194 | DP 344/882

STR 14 | DEX 13

INT 11 | WIS 13

DEF 17 | RES 16

CHA 13 | LUK 13

CON 14 | END 12

Resistances: Physical 90%. Divine Energy 50%. Dark Energy 50%.

Weaknesses: Fire 45%. Ice 15%.

Active Skills: Ashenzari's Senses, Ashenzari's Devotion, Ashenzari's Eyes.

Passive Skills: Cursed Body (Extreme), Mouth of Lies, Melee Weapon Prowess (High), Ranged Weapon Prowess (Medium), Others (37 more...)

Talent Slots: N/A

Prestige: N/A

* * *

If Timothy were in a more complete mental state he might be shocked out of his wits. The information given to him by Yredelemnul's Eye was far, far more complete than before. Previously, it wouldn't give him more than a single paragraph of information about Faceless, but now it gave him a fully detailed Character Sheet, complete with all his stats, the names of his skills, and even additional information about his source of power.

It didn't tell Timothy what Faceless's skills all were, or what they did, but it was good information to have!

He has a significant weakness to fire. Timothy thought. *Considering he's a water-based creature living in a forest, that makes sense. But it doesn't matter. My eye beams are too weak to hurt him now.*

Timothy lowered his head. He wanted to fight back, but all the fight had left him. There was nothing left to do. The battle was lost.

At that moment, there was a crackling noise inside Timothy's helmet.

[Timothy! This is Paimon! Your vitals say you've woken up. Do you read me?]

Timothy quietly switched to internal comms. "Yeah... I'm... awake, Paimon. I'm awake. Too tired. Can't think."

[I know, but I remembered something important! Timothy, I'm going to escape the dungeon. I don't know if me leaving will leave the rest of you behind, or if you'll teleport out with me, but even if the former is true, I'm going to be able to tell your mom what happened. If the Dungeon breaks, we might be able to get you all out!]

"No... don't... don't let the dungeon break." Timothy said quietly. "Chrona... will perish. Catastrophe. Don't let my mom die. Tell her... I'm sorry. For everything. *I'm sorry*."

Tears started to well up in Timothy's eyes. He'd arrogantly brought everyone here. He'd spread his game-powers around, and now he was going to leave his mother all alone, dying inside the Dark Forest.

At least Paimon would get out. At least he'd be able to relay what happened to the others outside.

It was a terrible ending for Timothy, Marigold, Ferral, and Raavul. If Timothy died, Paimon might die too, since he was 'only' a pawn. But maybe he wouldn't. Timothy didn't know, and his brain was too sluggish to think of all the different possibilities.

[Don't you give up on me, Timothy! Besides, you still have a chance to kill those bastards! Only you can do it!] Paimon urged.

"Me...? I can't do... anything..." Timothy said wistfully.

[Yes you can. Have you forgotten about...?]

Timothy's eyes widened. Paimon said something that momentarily shook him out of his mental stupor.

"Oh... *yeah*. I did forget. Paimon... Paimon... *thank you*... if we die here, live on. But if we make it out alive... I'll be thanking you in person..."

* * *

Faceless gloated for a minute or so. But eventually, when the hyuu-man lost all his spirit and let his head hang in disgrace, Faceless lost interest.

"Bah. Let's drag these weaklings, the thief, and the traitor back to the Golden Glade. I want twenty of the elites and two Water Lords to go after the one that escaped. Hunt him down and bring him back to me, dead or alive. I don't care about a coward's life."

Faceless took a step toward Timothy and forcefully grabbed his chin. He casually scratched at the helmet shielding Timothy's face, tearing it away to reveal... strange, why was the human smirking at him?

ZOT!!!

A mighty blast of energy fired from Timothy's eyes, slammed into Faceless's golden mask, and sent him flying backward. Faceless spun helplessly backward, end over end, battering his body multiple times until he crashed into a tree and his body fell limp.

The Water Lords holding Timothy stiffened in shock. They were completely taken aback by this abrupt change in circumstances. They had no idea Timothy possessed such a power, because Faceless hadn't told them. If they knew Timothy wielded such formidable magic, they might wonder how a 'mere thief' could activate Yredelemnul's Shard, and that could lead to other uncomfortable questions Faceless didn't want them asking.

As for the blast he fired earlier, it was so weak that they simply had no way of linking it to a mighty Ruler. It was likely just the hyuu-man's personal ability, weak and pitiful as he was.

Before the Water Lords could react, Timothy spun his head to look at the First Water Lord on his right.

"**VERMIN.**" Timothy said, his eyes glowing with evil purple color, his voice booming in the Sequid's mind.

A wave of terror swept over the First Water Lord. He instantly released Timothy's arm and leaped away, tripping over Sylphid's unconscious body. So panicked was the First Water Lord that he didn't even perceive his surroundings.

"AAAIYEE!!" The First Water Lord screamed, his voice high-pitched like a banshee. His scream made the hair rise on everyone's necks. And before they could properly come up with a plan or a counter-measure, Timothy turned to look at the Second Water Lord holding his left arm.

"**SUBMIT OR DIE.**" Timothy's voice boomed again, breaking the Sequid's psyche and making him scurry backward before diving to the ground and kowtowing at Timothy's feet.

"Forgive me!!" The Second Water Lord screeched while kowtowing. "I did not recognize His Majesty's greatness! I have sinned!"

Seeing the strongest of the Water Lords both losing their minds, as well as Faceless's body being ragdolled into the distance, the other elites had no idea what the hell was going on. The Seventh Water Lord tensed up, ready to leap at Timothy and go on the offensive, but the others took a few steps back, looking at him in fear.

"Th-this aura!" The Third Water Lord cried out, her eyes nearly popping out of her head. "Y-Y-Yredelemnul's power?! How has the hyuu-man mastered it? Is he a real Emissary after all?"

"HAHAHA." Timothy laughed wildly, hamming it up as he put on his best impersonation of an 'evil' voice. "You FOOLS. You walked right into my trap. Everything here was a test to assess your qualifications, and I have found you all LACKING."

"What nonsense is he speaking?" The Seventh Water Lord, also the youngest of them, asked. "Quickly, let's move in and-"

"**SILENCE.**" Timothy shouted, his words booming in the Seventh Water Lord's mind. At once, the weakest of the seven was cowed and shrunk backward, too terrified to make a move.

"I was wrong!!" He screamed. "Forgive this weakling, he did not know the true darkness until he saw it!"

Faceless shakily pulled himself to his feet. Timothy's eye-beams weren't actually as powerful as the ones he had unleashed inside Cthulhu's Chamber, when he had been under the effect of Player's Fixation. A 500% increase in mental focus was no joke. But this time, Faceless had completely let down his guard, thinking his victory was in the bag. As a result, he suffered even worse wounds.

"Cough, cough!" Faceless wheezed, as blood suddenly dribbled down his face.

He stood up, and Timothy looked over at him. For a moment, Timothy's evil grin faltered.

He couldn't believe what he was seeing.

Faceless... doesn't have a face! His name is more literal than I thought! What the hell, he has no mouth or nose, just like a Psion! But then how the hell has he been 'speaking' to me the whole time?!

Faceless's golden mask was shattered and broken. For the first time in an unknown number of years, his face, or lack thereof, was revealed to the world around him.

This was one of the worst curses he had inflicted on his body. It was what had allowed him to rise to the peak of the mortal realm, just a step away from becoming a Cosmic.

Unfortunately, the sad truth was, Emissaries were existences bound to their Rulers. They could never become Cosmics, but could be considered gods of the mortal realm. They managed their Ruler's lands, and were rewarded with power, wealth, fame, and any other things they wished. All for the glory of their 'gods'.

When Faceless coughed, blood seeped out of his skin, right from the area where his mouth ought to be. It was freaky, like watching a man spontaneously bleed out of his cheeks. It made Timothy's skin crawl.

"You..." Faceless wheezed, taking two slow and laborious steps toward Timothy. "Impossible... how could you... recover... you were... faking your injuries?"

Timothy smirked. "Nah. Nothing a little Full Restore couldn't fix. Too bad you don't have those, eh? Looks like Ashenzari isn't as caring toward you as Yredelemnul is toward me."

Faceless was in disbelief. He could see that the tables had drastically turned. Timothy's aura now radiated the full power of Yredelemenul, causing the Water Lords to think twice before attacking, especially after Timothy had subdued the two mightiest Water Lords with seemingly a single glance.

Those in the know, such as the Water Lords, were not ignorant fools. They knew the lineage of the Dark Ones, and their signature abilities.

Yredelemnul's ability to tear the void with his eyes, to strike at enemies with the powers of flame and ice, and the power to subdue others with a single glance were obviously a few of his core powers, passed on to his descendant. Since Yredelemnul had died eons in the past, during the war for Andromeda, it stood to reason this young man must be his inheritor.

A mere Emissary? What a joke! He was a direct Inheritor, and an Inheritor of the Dark Ones was far above their level. The fact they had manhandled him left their stomachs convulsing in regret. What the hell had Faceless been thinking, attacking the hyuu-man like that?! Was he suicidal? Did an Emissary like him not understand the stakes?!

The Third Water Lord's eyes widened. She suddenly realized something crucial, as she pointed an accusatory finger at Facless.

"Y-you! You knew all along! You were trying to steal the shard for yourself! You FOOL of an Emissary! Greedy, non-filial descendant! You seek to usurp the will of Yredelemnul and take it for yourself! Does your appetite know no limits?!"

When she spoke, it was as if a veil had been lifted. Not only the Water Lords, but the Sequid Elites turned enraged gazes toward Faceless.

Faceless's heart went cold. The secret was out. He was finished now. If he were in his peak state, he could potentially kill the others and take Timothy's power for himself, but now he was mortally wounded. If he didn't recuperate for ten years, he wouldn't fully recover from his injuries.

"D-don't listen to the hyuu-man's lies!" Faceless shouted. He looked desperate, like a raving madman. "He stole Yredelemnul's power! He found a way to harness it! That power belongs to us, to the Dark Ones! He's not one of us!"

"Hahaha!" Timothy laughed, puffing out his chest. "Your words betray you, Faceless! How dare you denigrate the authority of a Dark One! Who are you to determine my lord's

whims? He delivered this power unto me, and I accepted it. Do you truly believe any mortal could so easily take control of a Dark One's powers otherwise?"

The Water Lords frowned in response. It was true, a Dark One's power was that of a fallen Ruler. Apex Cosmics could potentially harness it, maybe even High Cosmics, but a mortal would be unable to, unless the Dark One had altered his power to be compatible with the mortal's body. In fact, even if a Peak Mortal like Faceless were to obtain Yredelemnul's power, he would likely explode into a pile of meat and gore, because he would be unable to control it, let alone this seemingly weak hyuu-man.

"Faceless, for your insults and crimes against Yredelemnul's Heir, I sentence you to death." Timothy boldly stated, puffing out his chest even more. He looked down his chin at the wavering Faceless, as if gazing upon an ant. "Kill yourself now, or I shall sever you from Ashenzari's Will and strike your name from the history books!"

Faceless's eyes contorted into a visage of rage. He leaped at Timothy and stretched out his hand to grab for Timothy's neck.

"Not if I kill you FIRST!" Faceless roared.

Timothy's eyes glowed red. "Then die alone, heretic."

ZOOOOOT!

A focused, concentrated beam of fire crashed into Faceless, but he deliberately didn't dodge. This time, his full guard was raised, and he concentrated all the darkness within his body to resisting the beam of flames.

"Uaaahh!!" Faceless screamed as he held up an arm defensively and continued to press forward, enduring against Timothy's attack even as Timothy maintained it at full-force.

This was not like earlier, a single-second shot of power. It was a focused beam that started growing more powerful every second as Timothy rapidly felt what remained of his mana start to drain.

"Uuurgh!" Timothy groaned, his eyes burning from the strain.

"I'll! Kill! You!!" Faceless shrieked.

The Emissary drew within just a few feet of Timothy, and he reared back his one free arm to deliver a killing blow. Even if he couldn't take Timothy's shard, so long as he slayed Yredelemnul's Heir, he could lie about the situation, deceive the others, and pretend Timothy was putting on a front the whole time.

Timothy's fierce expression turned into a smile as he continued to pour mana into his eyes. "Idiot. You fell for it again."

Timothy's voice boomed in Faceless's mind. "**SURRENDER!**"

Yredelemnul's Disdain activated at the same time as Yredelemnul's Rage. The effects of activating both powers together was truly stupendous. All at once, Faceless's body lost its strength. He lowered his defenses unwillingly as the Terror effect seized his mind. His arms fell to his sides, and Timothy's fire-laser pierced his body, torching a hole through Faceless in less than a second. With a deliberate upward sweep of his eyes, Timothy bisected Faceless's body vertically, which melted his skull into slag.

Faceless instantly died. The left and right halves of his body plopped against the ground, landing in a splash of dried, burned blood, the stench of his corpse reeking of burned meat.

* * *

[You have defeated Ashenzari's 3rd Emissary.]

[You have acquired 22,141 gold.]

[You have acquired 1x Soul of Faceless (Broken)]

[You have acquired 2x Faceless Lootboxes.]

[You have acquired Ashenzari's Skillbook: Curses to Power.]

[Ashenzari has noticed your presence. Ashenzari is looking at you with interest.]

[Level-up x4. Additional experience banked.]

[You have reached Level 25. You have acquired your first Promotion. Until you choose a Promotion, you will not be able to level up any further. After choosing your Promotion, any additional experience you have acquired will be re-routed to your Promotion Level.]

* * *

Timothy acquired a mountain of rewards, but he wasn't in the mood to focus on all these extraneous things. He had bigger issues to worry about.

If the other Sequids had any doubt before, they were completely convinced now that Timothy was, indeed, the true heir of Yredelemnul. Their legs gave out, and they sank to their knees, kowtowing to him as if bowing to a god made manifest in the flesh.

"All hail Yredelemnul's Heir! All hail Lord Timothy, the mighty hyuu-man!"

Timothy's shoulders sagged. The others were too terrified to notice that with his mana fully drained, the aura of Yredelemnul had completely faded. Timothy was defenseless again, at least unless he used another Full Restore.

"It is... good that you have finally recognized my majesty." Timothy said, turning to them with a domineering attitude. "In light of Faceless's deception, I shall grant the lot of you clemency. However, how dare you still hold my subordinates captive?! Release them at once!"

Struck dumb by his words, the few Elites who were pinning Marigold and the others to the ground suddenly leaped up and retreated ten steps, as if they had been bitten by snakes. Thinking better of their attitudes, they quickly rushed forward again and helped Marigold up, along with both Psions and Sylphid as well.

* * *

Time passed. Timothy managed to let Paimon know what had happened. Paimon was, naturally, over the moon about Timothy's victory. He made his way back, and Timothy had the others use one of their Full Restores to fix themselves up. Unfortunately, Paimon did not have such a thing, and Full Restores could not be used on other people, but he wasn't injured anyway, so it was fine. In the future though, if he was injured, he wouldn't have as convenient a get-out-of-trouble-free card as the actual Players did.

Timothy had to wake Sylphid up gently, allowing her consciousness to stir. Her pitch-black eyes slowly blinked open, and she smiled when Timothy told her about Faceless's death.

"Timothy..." Sylphid said, her words wobbly due to the head injury she'd suffered. "I'm glad you made it. I knew I was right... to trust in you."

Marigold rubbed her scaled arms. She glowered at Sylphid from afar, then turned up her nose.

"Hmph."

Part 754: Darkness Departs

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Dark Forest, Golden Grove.

Timothy and the rest returned to the Golden Grove. This time, they traveled much more quickly, as Sylphid and the Seven Water Lords buoyed them along. It only took them an hour to return, which showed that Faceless must have been duped by their simple deception early on and gone the wrong direction at first. Otherwise, how could he have not caught up with them sooner?

Timothy's group had killed quite a few of the Sequid Elites, twenty-three in total. He and his friends had also badly burned and injured fifty more. For three quarters of the elite Sequids to be injured or dead, it truly showed how formidable Timothy's tiny fighting force had been.

Part of the reason they dealt such a grievous blow was because their weapons and technology had caught the Sequids off-guard. But another reason was simply because the Sequids foolishly assumed Timothy's group were all weaklings and posed no threat. If they had been on their guard from the beginning, they would have won an overwhelming victory.

Timothy thought about these things, and more.

Warfare is just as much about psychological trickery and deception as it is about superior strength and firepower. It's also harder to learn... perhaps I should focus more on overcoming my foes through bluffing and deception in the future. The results proved outstanding here. For such a small material cost to produce such an outstanding result, why shouldn't I use similar tactics moving forward?

Timothy directed an ugly gaze Ferral and Raavul's way. Unfortunately, Timothy was still stuck using his Mind of Void for more than half a day, so he was extremely psiophobic at the moment. Even just looking at the Psions made him angry, and a little nauseous.

The good thing was, the Psions were already aware of this fact. They had practiced using each of Timothy's mental states on a few occasions under Blinker's supervision. Timothy had hurled some severe slurs at both of the Psions, but once they realized it was the King Network altering his thoughts, how could they blame him?

Psions were proud existences. Even an oddball like Ferral, who pursued interests distinct from his peers, was not one to be consumed by emotional constipation. He disregarded any nasty things Timothy said as if Timothy were momentarily acting like a spoiled, angry baby. Eventually, Timothy would switch out of the Mind of Void and return to normal.

One of the interesting facets of the Mind of Void was that, for some reason, it made Timothy a bit more cunning than usual. His thoughts became malicious, selfish, and his ego inflated as well.

Defeating Faceless only made Timothy act even more arrogantly. He couldn't stop crossing his arms and looking around haughtily as the Water Lords and Sylphid swept his group back to the Golden Grove.

* * *

Upon returning to the Golden Grove, Sylphid and the Water Lords found out that Sylphid had never actually been ousted as an Emissary of Ashenzari. Faceless had lied to everyone, seeking to take advantage of the confusion to eliminate his sole competitor in the Dark Forest, steal Timothy's power, and break free of his status as an Emissary.

Whether he would have been able to do so was up in the air. At the very least, if he couldn't take Yredelemnul's power for himself, he might have been able to offer it to Ashenzari for further concessions. Perhaps the Dark Forest Ruler might have even rewarded him with a chance at ascending to Cosmic, though that was an extremely unlikely option. Emissaries were never given such privileges, as that went beyond the scope of their roles.

What his ultimate plans were, nobody knew. They could take stabs in the dark at guessing his motives, but now that he was dead, those didn't matter. Dead men told no tales.

Timothy was now a genuine guest of honor. He smiled smugly as the various high lords and other leading members of the Golden Grove fawned at his feet, with Sylphid introducing Timothy as an Inheritor of the Dark Ones. News of his emergence would naturally cycle throughout the realm, and ultimately make its way to other worlds and galaxies far away...

But that was a story for another time.

After enjoying a feast, Timothy was tempted to take a long rest, but then Paimon appeared at his side and whispered in his ear. "Timothy, we have less than two days left before the Dungeon breaks. We need to be going."

Timothy's enjoyment of his new status quickly waned. He tapped his chin thoughtfully and nodded. "You're right. As much fun as it is being worshiped, these people are still the enemies of our galaxy. We've spent too much time here already. We should go."

And so, Timothy called Sylphid over to talk to her in private. She was now the highest ranked person in the Golden Grove, and held ultimate authority until another Emissary would be sent at some point in the future. Ashenzari had a rule that there should always be two Emissaries controlling key locations, both for redundancy and to ensure one person couldn't solidify too much power.

After they stepped into a side hallway where they could talk alone, Sylphid opened up the discussion with a heartfelt plea.

"Lord Timothy..." Sylphid said quietly. "I wish to go with you back to your homeland. I will renounce my status as Ashenzari's Emissary and become your follower. Once you ascend to the level of Ruler, I will become your Emissary instead."

Timothy was surprised. "You want to come along? I was going to do it before, because I felt we'd robbed you of your title and status, but now you have more authority than ever before. It would be better if you stayed here."

"I do not wish to stay here..." Sylphid said, her large black eyes meeting his. "I am... drawn to you. I wish to remain at your side."

Timothy swallowed heavily. He averted his eyes and felt a strange feeling in his body. He wasn't stupid, and could tell she was trying to seduce him. The problem was... it was starting to work. That made him feel good in an egotistical, or perhaps masculine way, but it also made him feel extremely guilty when he thought about his girlfriend's feelings.

"Ahh... I, I can't." Timothy said, taking a step back. "I just can't. No offense, but I don't think my companions will ever be able to fully trust you. And furthermore, I can't allow a relationship to develop between us. I already have a girlfriend. In my culture, monogamy is strongly encouraged. Besides, Marigold doesn't seem to like you, and I have to consider her feelings first."

"Oh, so you are looking at things from that perspective. I see." Sylphid said, as she also took a step back. "But... you are overthinking the matter. I cursed my fertility in order to serve Ashenzari. I am unable to bear you progeny. This is extremely common among Emissaries, as our Rulers do not wish us to create a legacy of heirs. Thus, I will not compete with your sexual partner for the status of first mate. I am satisfied merely becoming your... mistress."

"COUGH COUGH!" Timothy choked, his face turning crimson. The Sequid Emissary really had a bold way with words! She didn't hold anything back! "It's- it isn't about just bearing children, Sylphid! Even now, we're on the verge of emotional infidelity, and I don't think it would be a good idea for us to get any closer. Let's also not forget that you originally tried to *kill me*. How do I know you won't do such a thing again? I just cannot fully bring myself to trust you. Surely you understand this much?"

This seemed to get through Sylphid's head. She put on a difficult, hesitant expression and she touched her lips and swayed shyly from side to side.

"If... if that is the way my Lord feels..."

"It is." Timothy quickly said. "You should stay here, Sylphid. We come from different worlds, different cultures. I think you'll do better here than you ever would alongside me."

"No!" Sylphid said, stomping her foot. "I'm not staying. I refuse! And if you don't trust me, that leaves only one method..."

Timothy's heart jumped. He felt an ominous premonition from her words, but he wasn't sure what she was thinking.

Sylphid gritted her teeth, then she tapped her forehead, and her entire body shuddered with pain. She squeezed her eyes shut, then slowly pulled out a small marble of light from her glabella.

"H-here, my Lord. Take this." Sylphid said, her voice shaky. "I'll become your soul-slave! You can be assured I'll never betray you, hurt you, or turn against you, no matter what you say or do. If you want me to kill myself, I'll do it immediately! And if you want me to serve you... in any way... I'll... I'll do it willingly..."

Sylphid held up her hand, and the marble of light pinched between her fingers shone with her soul aura. It seemed she had extracted a fragment of her soul to offer him so that he could completely control her however he wanted.

Timothy's face twisted. "This- slavery?! No way. That's evil. Why can't you accept what I'm saying, Sylphid? This is unreasonable. We have to part ways."

"NO!" Sylphid shouted. "I don't want to! If you won't bring me along, and you won't even accept me as your slave, then... I'll just end my life now! I don't want to live without you!"

Timothy was dumbstruck. He hadn't even known Sylphid for a day. Had he struck her with Yredelemnul's Disdain at some point and overrode her thoughts? Had he accidentally brainwashed her without even knowing it? Why would she care so much about coming along with him? Was it so she could gather intel for her Rulers regarding the Milky Way? Was it because he was just so dashing and handsome that she fell in love with him at first sight? Was his status as an Inheritor really all that good? A combination of all of them? Something different??

Timothy had no idea. The mind of a woman was utterly foreign to him.

"Don't do that." Timothy said, his eyes hardening. "Don't try to pull some manipulative shit on me. Threatening to kill yourself if I don't take you as my slave? What's your real goal?"

Sylphid's expression was serious. "I want to stay by your side, no matter what."

"Yeah? Why?" Timothy pressed harder. "No lies. Only the honest truth. If you can't give me that much, then I will leave you to die here, whether you're serious or bluffing."

Sylphid closed her eyes. A long silence followed.

Timothy looked at her face and waited. She kept her eyes closed, as if thinking carefully.

Eventually, she opened them again.

"I have reached the end of my journey, Timothy." Sylphid said, her words seemingly cryptic at first. "This is it for me. I will stay here in the Dark Forest, possibly shuffled to another location at my Ruler's whims. My Ruler is stagnant. Ashenzari will grow no further. There will be Galaxy Wars someday, and I may even play a part in them, but ultimately I have reached the end of my journey."

She paused before continuing.

"I see a different path following you. You are weaker than me, but you have strong potential for growth. I see a much more exciting life ahead of me if I stay at your side.

Whatever our relationship might be, I wish to see what you will become. If I am with you, the gains might pass on to me as our relationship deepens. Whether I am viewed as lesser than your First Mate or not, that does not matter to me. All that matters is watching your journey as you climb toward the apex of power in the universe. I believe that someday... you will reach it."

Sylphid shivered with anticipation. "Please accept my soul shard. I do not mind being your slave. I only fear that if you were to leave me behind, I would be consumed with regret at the journey I never was able to witness. I would rather die if you forced me to stay behind."

* * *

Timothy looked away.

He didn't know what to say. Sylphid was a zealot, a religious wackjob who seemed to view the world through a lens of black and white. He was a little afraid of bringing her home. He also knew Marigold was going to be extremely angry if he did.

On the other hand, it seemed Sylphid wasn't just threatening to kill herself to emotionally manipulate him. She was extremely plainspoken, and the only time she'd deceived him was when she pretended she couldn't understand his friends' words. Well, that and tricking him into coming with her to have Yredelemnul's Shard sucked out. But those were really part of the same deception, and she could almost be forgiven since he was an intruder in her domain.

Timothy massaged his forehead and sighed.

He felt like he didn't have a win-win choice in front of him. And the truth was... he did enjoy Sylphid's company.

He did enjoy being around her...

Did that make him a lecher? Unfaithful? A bad man?

This was probably the case, but... he wasn't sure.

"Alright." Timothy eventually said. "I will accept your soul shard. But you will continue to address me as Timothy, not 'master' or any weird shit. I also don't plan to command you to do anything vile. Just don't hurt me, my mother, or any of my friends, and you can have your full autonomy. Got it?"

Timothy was scared that if he didn't take her Soul Shard and he brought Sylphid back, she would be stronger than even Blinker! If so, then she alone would be able to wipe out Chrona. He simply couldn't bring himself to fully trust her.

And so, Sylphid nodded. She bowed at the waist, then held up her hand, allowing Timothy to take the marble-sized orb from her.

* * *

[Sylphid's Soul Shard x1 Obtained]

Sylphid's Soul Shard [Passive Skill] [Legendary] [Enslavement]

Grants total control over the actions of Emissary Sylphid. The player's mind will be linked to Sylphid's, and the Player will be able to read her thoughts, but the reverse is not true. Slaves do not have the power to see their master's thoughts without permission.

The Player cannot control Sylphid's thoughts, but any command will be followed without hesitation. If Sylphid wishes to resist, she may 'understand' commands differently than the Player intended. The Player must be specific with commands if disobedience becomes a problem.

* * *

Timothy felt a pit open up in his stomach. Now that it was all said and done, he had gained total control over Sylphid... but he didn't like the way it made him feel. He could sense Sylphid's surface-level thoughts now, but he had no control over them, so there was that at least. He could tell that her passionate feelings toward him were genuine, but that only made him feel even more uncomfortable.

Timothy squeezed his eyes shut and pinched the bridge of his nose.

The new situation was... far from ideal.

"Let's... let's go." Timothy said quietly.

"Of course, master." Sylphid said, smiling cheerfully at him.

"No! None of that. You will just call me Timothy, or Lord Timothy if it makes you feel better. Don't ever call me 'master' or it'll lead to misunderstandings."

"What sorts of misunderstandings?" Syphid asked, cocking her head mischievously. "I'm your slave now, which means you're my master! There's simply nothing to

misunderstand."

"Don't say it again!" Timothy said. "Or I'll command you to jump off a cliff!"

Sylphid pouted. "Very well, Commander. I won't call you the M-word anymore."

"Wait, why are you calling me COMMANDER now??" Timothy asked.

"Well because I'm your slave and you command my actions, silly!" Sylphid laughed.

"UGH!" Timothy groaned.

He spent some more time adding more and more commands onto Sylphid's psyche to keep the naughty Emissary in check, ultimately finding that she was very good at finding loopholes in his mental commands. The good news was, she only seemed to want to find new and innovative ways to assert his dominance over her... which made him wonder if she was a masochist or something. Did she just love being controlled by someone mightier? Was that similar to her former relationship with Ashenzari?? It was a real headache.

Timothy and Sylphid eventually stepped back into the main chamber. He told Sylphid to make preparations for his departure, then he left to find his friends.

Timothy found the Psions meditating at the head of the table for guests of honor, Paimon was casually munching on the cooked leg of an unknown forest creature, and Marigold was sitting in front of a large plate of untouched food. Her arms were crossed, and as soon as she saw Timothy, she gave him a glare of annoyance.

"You were sure gone a long time!" Marigold chuffed. "Having fun with Sylphid?"

"I wouldn't say it was 'fun'..." Timothy said hesitantly. "But um... she's going to come back with us to Chrona. I got her to make a pledge with her soul that she won't harm any of you, me, my mother, or anyone else I consider my allies."

"Fine. Whatever." Marigold said. "Just do what you want."

Timothy's stomach started to sink. "Come on, Marigold... can we talk privately?"

"There's nothing to talk about." Marigold said coldly. "Let's just hurry up and go home before this Dungeon breaks and kills everyone I love."

Timothy could sense that his relationship with Marigold was shattering bit by bit. He didn't know how to fix it either. He'd brought her into the King Network, lifted her up,

had all sorts of good times... and now, wasn't he pushing her away? Ever since they entered the Forest, it had been one blunder after another.

"Marigold..." Timothy said quietly. "I love you, okay? I'm not going to cheat on you with Sylphid or something like that, okay? There's nothing between us."

"Just shut up already!" Marigold snapped. "You're really pissing me off."

Timothy wanted to say something, but it seemed everything he did say only made her madder and madder.

He knew it was his fault. He shouldn't have accepted Sylphid. He should have left her behind. Now he'd ruined his relationship with his girlfriend...

A lump formed in Timothy's throat. He turned and left the table, sitting off to the side of the dining hall as he waited for Sylphid to arrange a quick passage through the Forest as her last act as Ashenzari's Emissary.

Unfortunately, in order to properly step down from her position as Emissary, Sylphid needed to have many of her powers stripped away, and this required a ritualistic ceremony to do properly. It was true that if Faceless's claims had been correct, Sylphid could have had her powers violently stripped away by Ashenzari, and she would have been executed afterward, but since she was leaving to follow a future Ruler of the Dark Ones, she was considered as being 'honorably discharged' from Ashenzari's service. That meant she wouldn't have to give up all over her power, only specific portions of it.

Sylphid was going to lose much of her power. She would drop to the level of a Demon Duke, still stronger than all the rest of Timothy's party, but no longer capable of threatening Chrona.

When Timothy learned this, he had mixed feelings. He originally thought Sylphid would be way stronger than Blinker, so bringing her back to Chrona would be dangerous. But if she was greatly weakened, then enslaving her soul felt unnecessary and vile. It made his stomach cramp up even worse than before.

"Everything's all fucked up." Timothy muttered to himself. "All of it. I really stepped in shit this time."

While Timothy was wallowing in his emotions, a familiar figure seemingly appeared by his side out of thin air. Ferral took a seat next to Timothy and rested his palm on the young man's shoulder.

[Timothy. Something is troubling you.]

Timothy glanced at the Psion in disgust, but quickly forced his hatred of Psions into his stomach. His self-loathing was so strong that it was even overpowering the Mind of Void.

"I screwed up. Big time." Timothy mumbled. "I chose Sylphid over Marigold. Not literally, but enough to hurt Marigold's feelings. I think our relationship is over. I just didn't want Sylphid to kill herself, and now Marigold hates me."

Ferral folded his palms together. [The mating habits of other species are endlessly fascinating, but I possess no particular knowledge regarding their intricacies. Whether or not you have made an error is beyond me.]

Ferral continued. [I will say this, however. Timothy, you are still very, very young. So is Marigold. The two of you are emotionally immature, and liable to make mistakes. Even young Psions make mistakes, you know. I've made plenty of errors of judgment, including the very same ones that caused my Progenitor to cast me aside. So in this regard, while I cannot speak to the nature of your romantic relationships, I can speak to making mistakes and learning from them.]

Ferral paused.

[I spoke to Raavul a little while ago in secret. She has expressed some doubts regarding Sylphid. Are you aware that the fairies once controlled the Andromeda galaxy until the Dark Ones drove them out? By bringing Sylphid back with you, you could be putting Miss Blinker in an awkward situation.]

Timothy was surprised. "I didn't know about that."

[Neither did I. Raavul only picked it up by happenstance some years ago while speaking to Blinker. Blinker is a Fairy Queen, albeit not one who ever spent much time on the homeworld. She is aware of certain Truths, even the ones that occurred long before she was born. You should consider how to handle a situation involving Blinker and Sylphid meeting and a... *violent reaction*... occurring.]

Timothy's face fell. "You're saying I shouldn't bring Sylphid back with us? Is it really that dangerous?"

[On the contrary.] Ferral said. [You have not fully considered the strategic value of Sylphid. She is about to be severely weakened, and will be all alone with us in our

homeland. We will have a huge advantage. We can press her for detailed information regarding the Dark Ones. Sylphid is not some nameless nobody, Timothy. She is an Emissary of the Dark Ones, someone with vast knowledge of how they function.]

Timothy was enlightened. He thought about Ferral's words further. Now that Sylphid had submitted her soul to him, she would basically have to answer any of Timothy's questions unconditionally.

It did feel dirty, using her like this. Timothy wasn't in a rush to press her for information, but Ferral was right. She had a ton of strategic value to humanity. She might have wanted to come with Timothy for secret reasons involving espionage, scouting out humanity's capabilities, and reporting back to the Dark Ones, but even if that was true, couldn't he do the same to her?

Once again, Timothy felt a little nauseous. It seemed as if he were about to take advantage of Sylphid. She had nearly killed him before, but in the end she hadn't really hurt him, and she had fully submitted. Was it really right to treat her like a machine that gave out information at his whims?

"Ferral..." Timothy said quietly. "I have to confess something to you. Please don't tell anyone else.

Ferral nodded. [Anything you wish for me to keep secret, I shall do so.]

Timothy breathed a sigh of relief. Ferral really was a great friend. Timothy almost didn't completely hate him for being a disgusting mind-reading creature.

He quietly filed Ferral in on the details about Sylphid submitting her soul to him and how she couldn't disobey Timothy's orders.

Ferral stroked his chin. He fell into thought after Timothy revealed this new Truth.

[Clever female.] Ferral said. [Do you think this was not within the realm of Sylphid's planning? If she were to submit to you, she would not be so foolish as to overlook you interrogating her for information about the Dark Ones. I believe this ceremony has multiple purposes, with the new context you've given me. It is quite likely Ashenzari's Devoted will strip much of Sylphid's most sensitive memories away.]

Ferral gave Timothy a look of warning. [If you do question Sylphid, be aware that while she might not be able to lie to you, if the Dark Ones were to implant false memories

inside of her mind, she would only see them as the truth. She would not even be aware she was lying to you.]

"There's such a thing??" Timothy asked, aghast.

[Psions have used such tactics in the past. It is quite common among global powers. Who would allow their Emissary to travel alone to a hostile galaxy with key secrets bouncing around in their mind? Only a fool.]

Ferral patted Timothy's back.

[For what it is worth, I think you've mostly made all the right decisions.] Ferral said. [It is obvious some form of lust is guiding your actions toward Sylphid, but I see plenty of evidence that you have logically considered the consequences as well.]

Timothy quietly coughed. Why did everyone he know talk about such embarrassing things so plainly? It was really disturbing. Maybe he had too many non-humans hanging around him...

After Timothy and Ferral chatted, the Psion departed. Sylphid left for an hour to attend her ceremony, then returned. Her aura was far weaker than before.

Sylphid smiled sweetly at Timothy when she reappeared. "The ritual was... a success. I am yours now."

"Cough, cough!" Timothy choked. "You don't need to say it in such a weird way, Sylphid. People might get the wrong idea."

"Or perhaps... the *right* idea?" Sylphid teased.

* * *

Some time later, Timothy and the rest of the group started flying through the forest. Sylphid was with them, as were the Seven Water Lords. They used their superior power to shuttle the group towards the north end, at Timothy's discretion.

Sylphid believed in Timothy, but even she was skeptical of his claims regarding an 'edge' to the forest. Everyone knew this world was covered entirely by forest, and even its oceans and lakes were submerged in darkness by the impossibly tall trees that sprouted from the bottom of those ancient waters.

How could there be an edge?

But, after a full day of travel at far higher speeds than Timothy ever could have managed, the young man started to feel a weird 'pinging' sensation in his mind. He realized it was the 'objective' calling out to him.

"That direction!" Timothy called out, slightly altering the flight path of the Water Lords.

All along the way, the forest's other denizens strictly avoided them. Nobody knew yet that Sylphid had lost her power, so she alone was a huge deterrence, but the Water Lords were even scarier with their powers together. At least Sylphid could only hunt and kill a small group of enemies one by one. The Water Lords could spread out and take down an army of Stalkers if the need arose!

Thus, the Water Lords obeyed Timothy's command as if he were Ashenzari himself. They adjusted course and traveled toward an unknown location.

Eventually, a faint light emerged in the darkness ahead. Timothy squinted to see it, but it rapidly became brighter and brighter as they drew nearer.

It turned out there was no northern edge to the forest, at least not as expected. Instead, there was a hole punctured in the roof of the forest, allowing blinding white sunlight to pour through the canopy, blinding those who were too accustomed to the shadows. Sylphid winced slightly, as did the Water Lords. Eventually, they set down at the bottom of the shaft of light.

"This is... the edge of the forest?" Sylphid asked skeptically. She gave Timothy a sardonic look. "It's just a hole in the canopy."

The First Water Lord frowned. "This is the first of such a thing I've seen in all my years. How powerful would an entity have to be to risk tearing a hole in the canopy and having it remain? The trees of the Dark Forest are strong. They can regrow to cover such holes in minutes, yet this one remains after all this time."

He gave Timothy a knowing look. "The power of Yredelemnul's Eye is beyond comprehension. I see you've made plans for a while, young one."

Timothy scratched his head awkwardly. He didn't know what to say. "It was my master's will, that's all."

"I am gladdened by Yredelemnul's plans. He was truly a wise and far-seeing Ruler to have laid such plans out for his Inheritor." The First Water Lord said.

After seeing that Timothy had made it to his destination, the Water Lords bowed deeply. They turned and flew away, leaving Sylphid with the rest of them.

Timothy glanced at Marigold. She didn't meet his eyes. She'd been deliberately avoiding him ever since she learned Sylphid was coming along.

"Alright..." Timothy said hesitantly. "Let's go home."

Invisible question marks popped up over Sylphid's head. The hole in the canopy was impressive indeed, but how was Timothy planning to depart the forest?

Timothy and the rest stepped into the shaft of light. At that moment, a quest box appeared.

* * *

DARK FOREST DUNGEON (COMPLETE!)

A forest filled with extremely powerful life forms. These life forms are vicious and bloodthirsty. Crossing them will likely mean death. In order to pass through, the party must move stealthily. If the Party inadvertently catches the attention of a powerful life-form, the party must quickly defeat their adversary and hide, lest more enemies are drawn to the scene.

Difficulty: Very Easy

Dungeon Level: 1

Dungeon Objectives: The Party must traverse the Dark Forest successfully. The Party will start at the southern edge of the Dark Forest. The Party must reach the northern edge before the time limit expires.

Time Limit: 1 Week.

Rewards if successful: Level 1 Dungeon Rewards x5. Bonus rewards obtainable if hidden criteria are met.

Penalty if failed: All party members +3 levels. Skip all level-up rewards. A Dungeon Break event will occur.

SUCCESS: Secret objectives not met. No bonus rewards will be given. Each Player will acquire 1x Level 1 Dungeon Reward.

* * *

A special lootbox appeared in everyone's inventory, except for Paimon. Paimon was a Pawn, so he didn't receive the reward.

Timothy glanced at it. It appeared to be a Dungeon Lootbox of some sort. It would surely give out decent rewards. Timothy was extremely angry that it was only considered a Level 1 Dungeon though... wouldn't he have died if he had entered it alone? What the hell was his group going to do when they faced even more difficult dungeons?

Timothy looked at Marigold again, then he looked away.

Marigold was an absolute badass during the final battle. She killed several Elite Sequids with her Thunder Gauntlets, only losing the battle when the Water Lords attacked her all at once. If she became estranged... Timothy would miss bringing her along for the future Dungeons.

Timothy decided not to bother with yet another Lootbox just yet. Instead, he was going to open all his rewards at home, alongside his mom and friends. Right now, he just wanted to get out of the Dark Forest and go home.

A portal appeared in the center of the light. Timothy glanced at Sylphid.

"Are you ready to go?"

Sylphid cocked her head to the side. "Of course. But... how are we going to leave?"

"Through the portal, of course." Timothy said, gesturing to it.

Sylphid followed his finger. She looked right at the portal, then back at Timothy.

"Um..."

"You don't see it?" Timothy asked, bewildered. "The portal. It's right there."

He walked over and stood just a few feet away from it. Then he waved his hand in a big arc to indicate it, but Sylphid simply raised an eyebrow.

"There is... no portal." Sylphid said. "Are you playing pranks on me?"

"No??" Timothy half-said, half-asked. The other five glanced at Sylphid, with Marigold looking quite amused by the situation, while the others were instead frowning.

"I guess we'll just have to drag you into it if you can't see it then..." Timothy said.

He walked over, hesitated for a moment, then made up his mind and took Sylphid's hand. He expected to see anger on Marigold's face, but when he looked at his girlfriend, she had no expression at all. It was as if she had fully given up on him.

Timothy felt bad once again, but he decided that at this point, the relationship with Marigold was probably done. There was no way of redeeming it anymore. As such, he might as well stop kicking himself over and over again.

Ferral flew into the portal. Then Raavul, then Marigold, and finally Paimon. After that, Timothy stepped through, pulling Sylphid along with him.

At once, they emerged inside the Grand Library, where the extremely tall Po was waiting.

"Welcome back, small friend." Po said, his words only comprehensible to Timothy. "Ah. You brought a character with you. From the book."

Po paused for a half-second.

"...I am truly sorry."

Timothy blinked. He looked at Po, then he turned to look back at Sylphid.

What Timothy saw shook him to his core.

As soon as Sylphid passed through the portal, her body shuddered. She slumped to her knees and started breathing heavily. Cracks of light ruptured all over her skin.

"T-Timothy... I don't-"

She was still holding his hand when her body exploded into motes of light, her body bursting apart into ash.

Timothy didn't get to say any final words. Sylphid simply died while holding his hand. Her death was sudden, violent, and completely unexpected.

Timothy froze on the spot. He looked back in horror as the dissipating particles of light where Sylphid once stood.

"S-Sylphid? SYLPHID?!" Timothy screamed.

He had brought her out of the Dungeon, and in doing so, he had killed her.

Timothy had killed Sylphid. All because of his ignorance.

"No, no! NO!" Timothy screamed, as he fell to his knees. The portal to the Dark Forest closed, leaving the other six to stare with a variety of emotions at the devastating scene. All of them were shocked, horrified or at the very least, discomforted by what had just happened.

All except for one.

"Ahahaha! Now there's a twist!" Marigold laughed. "Kyargh! Stupid bitch got what she deserved! HAHAHA!!"

Part 755: Lover's Spat

Far-Future Era. Day 20, AJR. Po's Library.

Marigold cackled uproariously. She grabbed her gut and threw her head back as she laughed, laughed, laughed at Sylphid's dissipating body, the last particles of of her corpse floating away as she turned to dust on the spot.

"Hahaha!!" Marigold shrieked. "Couldn't have happened to a shittier thief! God is real, and he has a sense of humor!!"

"What- what the FUCK is wrong with you?!" Timothy screamed, as he staggered to his feet and directed rage-filled eyes full of tears at Marigold. "Sylphid is dead! She's DEAD! And you think this is funny?!"

"It's hilarious!" Marigold laughed, as she closed her eyes and squeezed out tears of joy. "She tried to kill you, and you're getting all mopey-dopey about her dying. You're such a doofus, ahaha!"

Something snapped in Timothy's mind. He didn't even do it consciously, but his hand slapped the T-REX on his chest, causing the Thundercat armor to swallow his figure. His vision turned red as he jumped at Marigold and reared his fist back.

Thump!

Marigold's eyes were momentarily closed. She didn't see Timothy's punch coming, so he landed a clean blow on the side of her head and knocked her backward. Her tail quickly changed direction to steady her feet, and she didn't fall to the ground.

After taking a few steps to steady herself, Marigold's laughter abruptly died. She clutched the side of her head, opened her eyes, and her pupils narrowed to vertical slits.

"You... you little piece of shit!" Marigold chuffed. "Kyargh! You hit me?! Over that worthless slut?!"

"Fuck you!" Timothy shouted, directing a trembling fist at Marigold. "She wasn't worthless! I see now that you're just a shallow bitch who only-"

THUMP!!

Timothy didn't see Marigold's counter-punch coming. His words slurred. His vision dulled. He woke up on the ground, his eyes dancing and his head blearily yelling warnings into his mind. It felt like five minutes passed as he dreamily looked right and left, the world a mess of shapes and images that didn't quite fit together correctly. It was probably less than two seconds.

There was a pressure on Timothy's throat. He tried to swallow, but the action was blocked by something. His vision came into focus, and he saw the tip of Marigold's long snout less than an inch from his face. Her punch had destroyed part of his helmet and left him open to attack. He could smell her faintly earthen odor, something he once associated with lust, but now made him feel somewhat fearful.

Marigold's left hand wrapped around Timothy's throat tightly. He realized that was why he couldn't swallow, and that realization sent a wave of panic through his mind.

Timothy's heart jumped. He grabbed at the hand holding his neck, but he was too weak to pry her claws away, even with the Thundercat empowering his strength.

Marigold's eyes were cold. Any former trace of love for Timothy was gone, long gone. It was as if she had become a primordial predator, and he was the prey she held in her clutches.

"You're a stupid little fucker, Timothy. *Little Timmy*." Marigold sneered. "I put up with you all this time because I thought I could get more out of you, but you're not even worth the time anymore. Dumb little piece of shit. Kyargh! Here's a fun fact for you, *little Timmy*, I was thinking of baby-trapping you so my kids would be locked in as future Heroes. But then you gave me this awesome game power, so now I don't need them anymore! You can't take the power away from me, so your value has run out!"

The corner of Marigold's mouth curled up into a sneer. "I deceived you from the very beginning. All I had to do was bat my eyes and act like a dumb little ditz, give you some attention, and you gave me everything I wanted. Now I have the power to become the strongest crocodile in Chrona, even the strongest in the galaxy! I would thank you, but you're so *pathetic* it makes me sick."

"It's too bad." Marigold said with a small chuckle. "If you had just played along, I'd have kept the charade up to spare your pride. But you just had to be stupid and chase some other girl. Now you're paying the price, but you're still so stupid you think you can attack me without any consequences. Idiot!"

Timothy wanted to say something, to choke some words out, but he was horrified to find that Marigold's strength was way beyond what he could handle. She wasn't at the strength of a Demon Duke or anything, but she was a Crocodile enhanced by the King Network. Her innate strength was far, far above a wimpy little human like him. He was completely helpless in her grasp.

Even as Timothy had that thought, Marigold's grip started to weaken.

Timothy was baffled. Was she giving up? Letting him go?

But then, a voice spoke.

[Marigold. Release him.] Ferral said, his hand outstretched, focusing on using his psionics to try and pry Marigold's claws off Timothy's throat.

Marigold slowly turned her head to look back at Ferral. As a Psion, he was basically emotionless, logical, even cold. But in that moment, he felt a genuine pang of fear shoot through his heart.

"Don't. Get. Involved." Marigold hissed. "Stay out of this, Psion. I'll ruin you if you intervene. This is a lover's spat."

Ferral was momentarily frightened, but then his expression steeled. He hardened his eyes and sent an equally vicious glare back at her.

[There is no love between either of you anymore. Unhand my friend, Marigold.]

Marigold growled at Ferral. "Make me."

ZOT!!!

A blast of fire slammed into Marigold's chest and blasted her off Timothy's body. The power of Yredelemnul's Rage erupted from Timothy's eyes, tore Marigold off him, and sent her flying.

Marigold involuntarily screamed as she was launched toward the back end of Po's library. She crashed into a giant bookshelf and sent the entire display toppling backward into another bookshelf, causing a domino effect to play out. Po himself was watching the fight without involving himself, but when the shelves started to fall, Po let out a cry of alarm.

"Oh no. My books!"

Timothy coughed and spat. Firing at Marigold was a last resort option, but seeing as she had threatened Ferral, Timothy realized Marigold wasn't fucking around. She really, truly, was not who he thought she was. He thought about all the signs he'd overlooked, flashes of memories and 'minor' red flags playing out in his mind's eye one after another.

Her main active skill had been Charm. Did she use it on him?

He had continuously failed to receive high affection marks for his relationship with her, according to the King Network. Had she never actually felt any real love toward him since the beginning?

She hadn't seemed interested in the King Network at first, but was that only a facade? Was she secretly using reverse logic to get him to pass it on to her?

These and other issues appeared one after another in his memories. Timothy shook the thoughts away and staggered to his feet. His vision hadn't fully cleared up. Marigold had hit him so hard, he feared she'd given him a brain injury. He couldn't be sure, but it seemed like she really wasn't that much weaker than Faceless, though Timothy hadn't truly fought Faceless one-on-one, so he couldn't be sure.

Marigold's flying body eventually came to a stop, as did the collapsing bookcases. From the cloud of dust that had risen upward, due to the age of the books and tomes on those shelves, a hazy shadow of Marigold's body emerged. She stepped forward and cracked her neck.

She jumped out of the bookcases and landed on the floor. With this, Timothy, Ferral, Raavul, and Paimon all took a step back. They hesitantly created a collaborative formation, one they'd practiced many times before. The difference was, Marigold wasn't a part of it now.

"Hahaha..." Marigold chuckled. There was a terrible burn mark on her chest from where Timothy's eye-beams had exploded against her, but she didn't seem to feel pain. "So you're all going to take his side, huh? After he cheated on me?"

[You know that is not what happened, we know that is not what happened, and you know we know.] Ferral said, continuing to direct a steady gaze at Marigold. He positioned himself between the crocodile and Timothy, acting as a physical barrier. [Timothy is my closest friend. I will not allow you to hurt him any further, either with your body, or your words.]

[Ferral is my student.] Raavul added. [If you attack him, I will not hold back.]

"Timothy is my master, the one who summoned me." Paimon added. "Obviously, I'll be taking his side over yours. Especially after you tore your mask off and revealed your true self."

Timothy looked at Marigold. She looked at him.

It had all happened so fast, but Timothy was clear-minded now. His thoughts were sane, and his considerations were realistic.

Not a drop of love remained in his heart for Marigold. She had been manipulating him from the very beginning. Maybe she lied and said those things just to piss him off and hurt him, but he didn't think that was the case. To say Marigold was honest would be rather paradoxical, but in this situation, it seemed as if every word she'd said had come from the bottom of her heart. She had not spoken a lie.

It made Timothy feel a little better. Now he wouldn't feel bad if his former girlfriend got the comeuppance she so desperately deserved.

"What's the matter, *little Timmy*?" Marigold taunted. "Too much of a tiny-dicked human to fight a girl by yourself? Need to hide behind your friends?"

His masculine pride, what little he had, bristled at Marigold's words. But Timothy restrained himself. He had to be realistic. Even if he and Marigold fought while he wore a T-REX and she didn't, he'd lose badly every time. It would be like a child facing off against a sumo wrestler, or maybe a professional MMA fighter. Timothy was not her match even in the slightest.

"You got what you wanted." Timothy said, his throat dry and scratchy. "You took my power. Enjoy it. Get the fuck out of our faces, and don't talk to any of us ever again, you lying bitch."

"Oh, little Timmy has some backbone now that he's hiding behind his friends?" Marigold retorted. "*You think these weaklings can protect you?!*"

Marigold charged. She could move frighteningly fast when she wanted, her natural body speed far above the level of the others.

Ferral was prepared. He summoned his Wordsmithium marble and sent it flying at Marigold's face in an attempt to put her eye out, blind her, and cause extreme pain. The problem was, though this was his strongest attack, Marigold was well aware of it. She

swept her arm out and struck the marble, knocking it away with her scales. A second later, her fist struck Ferral's chest and sent him hurtling backward into Timothy.

Paimon had already activated his own T-REX. He waved his hand and tore up the floor of the library, grabbing rocks and dirt from underneath the floor to fling at Marigold in an attempt to slow her down. Marigold completely ignored him. His rocks were like the fists of a toddler striking a professional boxer's thigh. She barely even felt them. When that attack didn't work, Paimon switched to shooting his AR-15, but the bullets bounced right off her scales.

Raavul was the second strongest of the group. She put her full Psionic strength into trying to slow Marigold down. As a 3rd Level Psion, she harnessed strength on the level of a Demon Baron. Even so, her telekinesis only slowed Marigold a little, and Marigold grinned wickedly as she turned her attention on the Aspirator.

"**GROOOAR!**" Marigold roared.

A surge of fear went through Raavul's mind. She was caught off-guard, not understanding what had just happened, before the back of Marigold's hand slapped Raavul's face and sent her sprawling. Raavul fell to the ground, shaking in fear, her body trembling uncontrollably.

It turned out Marigold had recently acquired a new skill after all the levels she gained in the Dark Forest. Several skills, in fact, and she had already leveled some of them up. The one she used was a Warcry ability that could terrify opponents and leave them vulnerable for a few seconds, similar to Timothy's Yredelemnul's Disdain skill. The effect didn't last nearly as long, but it was more immediate and had a stronger effect.

"Marigold, no!" Timothy screamed. Even he felt scared by her approach, so he quickly moved Ferral out of the way and activated his strongest ability.

Zot!

With his mind scared and in disarray, Yredelemnul's Rage had much less effect than before. Marigold was on the alert, so she actually managed to dodge it the second time Timothy used the ability, then she slithered over to Timothy and threw a fast jab at his chest.

Thuck!

This one punch, with less than half her strength behind it, hit Timothy square in the ribs and transmitted most of the damage past his T-REX, into his lungs. Timothy flew backward and banged his back against the bottom of Po's giant desk. All the wind was driven from his chest, and he was left in a state of shock, unable to breath, gasping for air.

"Uh- uh, uhk!"

Timothy choked. He tried to breathe, but his lungs had momentarily stopped working. Marigold was on him in a second. She grabbed his face and pressed him against Po's desk, holding him in place while ignoring Paimon's gunshots. At this point, Paimon's only remaining move was to throw a grenade, and he obviously wouldn't risk that.

With Marigold's massive hand covering Timothy's eyes, he didn't have the option to use Yredelemnul's powers. This left him completely helpless.

"Oh, Timmy, you really thought you stood a chance! Kyargh!" Marigold laughed. "You're so pathetic. You were a fun toy for a while, but this is the end. We're through. I could snap your neck with a flip of my wrist, but I'm not so cruel I'd do that. I just wanted you to understand the gap in strength between us. You'll always be a weak little bitch compared to me. You should have known your place and worshiped my feet!"

Marigold started lightly punching, slapping, and abusing Timothy with her left hand. She didn't have to use much strength, and she was easily able to beat the shit out of him. Timothy wanted to scream, to shout, to beg for mercy, but her flurry of blows quickly beat him unconscious. She continued to batter his body even after that, just for fun.

Abruptly, a powerful wave of energy locked on to Marigold. Her body froze mid-movement, and she was startled, not sure which of the others had suddenly become so strong.

Then, she was torn away from Timothy and slammed onto the ground. Marigold's senses were jarred. Something picked her up again, then banged her on the ground again, again, and again. Three times in total, it was like a fully grown man body-slamming a kitten. For the first time since the fight began, it was Marigold who was utterly helpless.

Marigold was pinned against the ground, completely immobilized by a crushing pressure. Her eyes looked upward and she saw Po looking at her with an unfeeling, emotionless expression. Po said something, she wasn't sure what, then he flicked his finger and Marigold was sent flying away, toward the portal at the back of the library.

Marigold left out a yelp as she was ejected. With her gone, the room returned to silence.

It took thirty long seconds. Timothy shakily returned to consciousness, but he was in terrible shape. Multiple bones were broken. His face was mostly intact, but there was a hand-shaped bruise stretching out in all directions from where Marigold had grabbed him. He struggled to breathe; it felt like there were rocks rattling in his lungs. They might have been bone fragments.

Both of his arms were broken in multiple places. He had five fractured ribs. The pain was not too bad due to adrenaline, but within moments it started to intensify until it reached a 13/10 on the pain scale. Timothy couldn't even think. He was in such agony that he wanted to die. He had never felt such pain in all his life. Blood leaked from multiple contusions and cuts all over the front of his body.

"Ugh.. guh... huggg... guhh..." Timothy gurgled.

Paimon quickly ran over to his side. To say he was worried was an understatement of the year.

"Timothy. Timothy, Full Restore. Can you hear me? Use a Full Restore. I can't do it for you, okay? Look into my eyes, Timothy. I know it hurts. Use a Full Restore, come on, kid."

Paimon had to repeat his words multiple times. Timothy could not think, and he could barely even hear due to the blood pounding in his ears. He was in such a bad state that Paimon feared even the slightest touch would only cause him worse agony.

Ferral stood up. He wasn't in great shape either, but luckily Marigold had only hit him once. Sadly, even though he was a Psion, Ferral's body was not much sturdier than Timothy's. He had a fractured rib, and he was in a good bit of pain.

But seeing Timothy's state, Ferral knew his own injury was nothing to speak of. Ferral repeated Paimon's words, projecting them deep into Timothy's psyche, so his brain would understand even if his ears wouldn't.

It took a few agony-filled minutes, but eventually, Timothy mustered the strength to open his inventory and select a Full Restore.

The instant he did, his body fully recovered. All his injuries vanished, all the pain, and his HP as well.

However, the memory of that pain did not go away. The phantom pain was just as strong, and so too was the trauma of being physically assaulted by his former girlfriend. Timothy shakily stood up, then fell to his knees again. He started crying, and he couldn't stop. His body trembled for several long minutes, and he broke down, hiccuping and sniffling as he tried to regain his center of calm.

Paimon tended to Timothy, while Ferral walked over to help Raavul. Like him, she had only taken one hit, and her body was even a little stronger than Ferral's, but Marigold had struck her in the face and given her a brain injury. Ultimately, she and Ferral both opted to use a Full Restore to heal their conditions. It felt like a bit of a waste, given they could probably recover using Blinker's healing formation, but the situation was a little urgent.

It was fortunate Paimon hadn't gotten physically involved. He didn't have the option of a Full Restore, and he would have needed to use Blinker's healing formation to save himself.

Everyone came over to console Timothy, but their words fell on deaf ears. He was shaking with a mixture of fear, anger, rage, and terror, remembering and replaying each blow Marigold had struck. His mind couldn't help but replay the last fifteen minutes like a terrible movie montage, emphasizing his emotions more and more each time he recalled his pain.

The thought he'd been intimate with such a violent psychopath left him shaken in his beliefs, made him question his own judgment, and forced him to replay all their past interactions. He began to doubt his grip on reality. Did he even know what was really going on in the world? How could he have been so stupid as to love such a vicious person?

Timothy wanted to shut his mind off, to stop thinking about her attack. But he could not stop himself. His mind recalled each punch, each strike, each hit as if it were happening again and again, on repeat, only deepening the trauma.

With Timothy in such a state, The others decided not to leave Po's library just yet. They all sat down with him and stayed close, offering their support even while shaking their heads in dismay.

Ferral felt his own sense of guilt. He was a Psion. Shouldn't he be able to read people's thoughts? How could he have overlooked Marigold's true nature so easily? Certainly, he'd had his suspicions in the beginning, but he hadn't acted as a voice of reason for Timothy in a strong enough manner.

Ferral vowed to himself silently that he would rectify this shortcoming in the future. Never again would he be caught off-guard by someone else's lies and deceptions. Unknowingly, Marigold changed the entire trajectory of Ferral's growth. How this would play out in the future was something that would require a great deal of time to pass.

* * *

The group spent several hours inside Po's library. It took a while, but eventually Timothy managed to calm down, at least on the surface. Internally, he was a complete mess. No matter how he tried to ignore those awful, awful repeating thoughts, his brain refused to function properly. He replayed Marigold's words in his head, each time hurting himself just a little more as he saw the sneer on her face, the condescending way she looked at him, and her smug victorious expression when she was holding him in her grasp.

Timothy couldn't take it anymore. He didn't want to think these thoughts, to replay the memories of Marigold's attack.

It had already been well over 24 hours since Timothy needed to initially escape the Golden Grove. He had long ago deactivated the Mind of Void and returned to the Mind of Simplicity. What was unnerving was that the Mind of Simplicity granted Timothy a 25% resistance to Fear and Anxiety, and yet he was still in this sorry state. It just went to show how badly Marigold had hurt him on an emotional level.

After thinking for a minute, Timothy made a decision. He activated the Mind of Logic.

* * *

Mind of Logic

Player's emotions reduced by 95%. Player's thinking speed increased by 100%. Player becomes more adept at solving complex problems, but at the cost of maintaining social relationships. Personality altered to ENGINEER.

* * *

Just like that, Timothy's emotions disappeared. He became stone-cold, and all his repeating thoughts regarding Marigold faded away.

The change was immediate and obvious. Timothy had been trembling nonstop for hours now, so when he ceased doing so, the others noticed. Timothy's eyes became calm. He looked around, and cast aside those irrelevant thoughts about his former girlfriend.

Stupid. He had been stupid. Marigold was right. He was an idiotic child who fell for the whims of the first girl who shook her tail at him. Timothy felt neither sadness nor anger about this fact. He simply contemplated and comprehended the new Truth put before him.

Timothy opened up his quests. The old quest he had received about making Marigold his girlfriend had been crossed out. He still possessed the minor permanent benefits, specifically a 10% experience gain buff, but all the others had vanished. His body became a little weaker, and some of his innate resistances had disappeared.

Oh well. It was the price he had to pay for his ignorance. In the end, what was a small mental trauma compared to the value of learning not to trust wiley females who batted their eyes at him? Timothy now understood on a fundamental level just how naive he had been. He would never again allow himself to be victimized by someone like Marigold.

Timothy stood up. The others did too, giving him strange looks. Only Ferral understood immediately what had happened, just by noticing the altered mental fluctuations in Timothy's psyche, and the eerily calm look in his eyes.

[You've activated the Mind of Logic?] Ferral asked.

"Yes." Timothy answered. "I was too weak to withstand the trauma of my assault. But I am mentally strong now. My apologies for making you all worried."

Raavul and Paimon didn't know the details of Timothy's skill. Raavul merely felt reassured, sensing that Timothy's thoughts had become more Psion-like. This was quite agreeable in her eyes. Paimon was also happy to see that Timothy had so swiftly recovered.

[Timothy. The Mind of Logic is a crutch. I don't mind you using it temporarily, but you should only do so in moderation.] Ferral warned.

"Your concern is noted. Thank you, Ferral." Timothy said calmly. "It only now occurs to me how unprepared I was for the event of a backstabbing by a comrade. I will have to create contingencies for such occurrences in the future."

Timothy turned to Po. "Thank you for saving my life by repelling Marigold from the Library."

Po looked at the human with interest. "Po happy to help. Po does not like people who cause havoc in Po's library. Shelves knocked over. Your fault. Loud annoying noises.

Marigold's fault. Po will forgive transgressions this time, because your 'play' was fun to watch. Po will write story about the exciting battle in Po's Library."

Po paused. "...After Po fixes the bookshelves, of course. Sigh."

"Sorry about that." Timothy apologized. "Would you like us to help fix your library?"

"No need." Po replied. "Po is Librarian. Rebuilding the Library is Po's job. Accidents happen."

Timothy nodded. He wasn't going to press the issue, since he didn't think he could do much anyway. A single one of Po's books was twice Timothy's entire body weight. Let alone the shelves, which were likely as heavy as buildings. Maybe only the Psions could help him, and they weren't all that strong either.

"Marigold was ejected from the Library." Timothy said, turning back to the others. "She could be out there, waiting for us. When we emerge, I want all three of you to split up and go look for Blinker. She can put Marigold in her place."

[I can transmit my words directly to Blinker the moment we emerge.] Raavul said. [My telepathy can easily cover the majority of Chrona.]

"Then we'll do that." Timothy said.

After some more preparations, the group jumped out of the Library and arrived back on Chrona. They were fully alert and ready for an ambush, but it turned out that Marigold was nowhere in the vicinity.

What they did see left them absolutely floored.

"This... this is Chrona?!" Paimon gasped. "How has it changed so much? What happened while we were inside the Dark Forest?!"

The state of Chrona was far, far different from when they entered the Dungeon. It was beyond anything they could have imagined...

Part 756: Timothy's Trial

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy, Paimon, Ferral and Raavul were all frozen on the spot, completely floored as they looked at the Chrona that stretched out before them. It looked similar to the one they left only a week before, except far, far more advanced.

Numerous large buildings rose up into the sky. If the city had looked like a small town with a couple tall residential apartments in the past, now it looked more like a modernized city with offices, giant warehouses, roads, and even train tracks.

In the skies above, there were swarms of hundreds of drones buzzing about, boxes full of various objects being flown around from place to place. Long conveyor belts criss-crossed in the skies, carrying even more stuff around from place to place, as if Chrona had become a living shipping facility and these conveyor belts were its blood veins.

The city looked like it had leaped forward an entire epoch in advancement. Timothy and the others were so shocked that for thirty long seconds, they couldn't move a muscle and were simply looking around in bewilderment.

That was until a voice suddenly shouted. "There they are!"

Timothy shook himself out of his stupor. He looked down to see a pair of armored male crocodilian warriors approaching him, their postures alert and their eyes wary. Soon, dozens more crocodiles hurried over, all of them armed with guns and melee weapons as they surrounded the group.

"Huh? What the hell is this?" Paimon asked. "The heroes return home and this is our welcoming party?"

"Quiet!" A male crocodile said, striding into view. He was a tall male named Remus, the seventh son of Kar and Blinker, one of the second generation crocodiles who commanded a lot of prestige. Based on his uniform, he appeared to be the leader of a police force inside Chrona. "Don't make any sudden moves, Timothy, nor the rest of you either. Graugh! We have questions for you!"

Timothy's mind revolved quickly. With his Mind of Logic active, he could already piece together that something had gone wrong, and the crocodiles surrounding him were

unusually hostile.

Naturally, one conclusion leaped to mind.

"Are you treating us like this because of something Marigold said?" Timothy asked mildly.

"Watch yourself, softskin." Remus said, hardening his gaze. "You brutalized my great grand-daughter. Graugh... don't you dare try to slander her, thinking I'll let you get away with it."

"Brutalized?" Timothy asked. "It's you who should be choosier with your words. Don't you think you're being biased, only hearing one side of the story?"

"I can put two and two together!" Remus snapped. "Marigold was beaten and battered, a terrible burn mark melted across her chest. She told us you attacked her, and based on how there isn't a scratch on any of you, even an idiot can tell she was telling the truth!"

"Where is my mother?" Timothy asked. "I want to speak to her. And Blinker and Kar."

"Don't you worry, they're on the way." Remus said. "The Techmancer is very busy, but I'm sure she'll spare some time for her fallen progeny."

Timothy blinked. *Techmancer?*

Before long, another group of people arrived. Among them were Raavul's other students, Fiona, Blinker, Kar, and Marigold, along with her mother, father, and immediate family.

Timothy looked at his mother. On any other day, he would have grinned and smiled, running over to her with happiness. But Timothy was in the state of Mind of Logic, so his emotions were completely muted.

"Mom." Timothy said simply. "Can you tell me what's going on? How long have we been gone? What happened to Chrona."

Fiona also, under other circumstances, would have run over and hugged Timothy tightly. It was obvious to everyone in Timothy's party that a lot of time had passed, and there's no way Fiona wouldn't have been worried sick. For her not to burst into a smile and rush over to hug him... what the hell had Marigold told everyone?

Fiona maintained a calm and stoic expression. She looked the same as before, but there was something slightly otherworldly about her appearance. Timothy couldn't quite

put his finger on what had changed, but Fiona's body seemed more ghostly and transparent then before, but also far firmer and more corporeal. It was a contradiction that made no sense.

"Timothy..." Fiona said slowly, as she took a few steps forward, glanced at Remus, and nodded. She returned her attention to her son. "You've been gone for ten months. A lot has changed in Chrona as a result of my abilities. And with regards to the situation here... why don't you tell us what happened inside the Dungeon?"

Ten months.

Timothy was surprised for a variety of reasons. He hadn't expected seven days in the dungeon to translate into ten months inside of Chrona. He was even more surprised that Chrona had drastically changed so much after less than a year of work. Even a hundred years with Jason around hadn't changed it so much. Just what the hell had his mother been doing?

"No. We cannot let the fiend spin his lies before all these people." Marigold's father said. "He's been corrupted by the Dark Ones. Just listen to how he speaks! Graugh! This creature before us does not talk in the way Timothy did before he left! It's as if an alien has possessed his mind!"

Murmurs went up among the crowd of crocodiles. Timothy wasn't the most outgoing person, but as the son of Jason, plenty of crocodiles knew and had interacted with him over the years. Everyone knew he was a somewhat reticent boy, shy, certainly awkward. He often stumbled over his words and lacked confidence. Why did he have such a cunning light in his eyes now? How could he remain calm with all these weapons pointed at him? Was this really the same person they had known from a year before?

Blinker cleared her throat. "Actually, Timothy is probably talking like this because-"

"Grandmother, there is no need for you to make excuses for him!" Marigold's father interrupted. "Let him tell his side of the story, and we will compare it with what my daughter told us!"

"Did you just interrupt me, you disrespectful little scale-brain?!" Blinker suddenly screamed, startling Marigold's father. "Don't think I won't slap the crap out of you, young mister! I'll beat you black and blue if you try pulling a stunt like that again!!"

Marigold's father immediately shrank his neck and cowered. The other crocodiles nearby also took a step back. Blinker was, still, the undisputed most powerful existence in Chrona. When she got angry, not one of her descendants had the courage to run their mouths glibly.

"G-graugh. C-calm down, Mother." Remus quickly soothed. "I'm sure my grandson meant no disrespect. We just want to hear Timothy's side of the story. If we give him too much information, he could alter it to hide certain details."

Blinker opened her mouth to say something, then closed it after a moment and crossed her arms angrily.

"Fine! Timmy, you'd better tell us every single thing that happened in that Dungeon. I expect the others to chime in too if Timmy missed anything!"

Paimon and the rest nodded slowly.

[Of course.] Ferral said. [There seems to be a... misunderstanding. We would be happy to clear the matter up.]

[Whether or not this 'misunderstanding' is a simple one, or a series of intentional fabrications, that is still up for debate.] Raavul added, directing an emotionless look Marigold's way.

Not one person on Timothy's side thought for a second that Marigold hadn't spun a tall tale to fool the crocodiles. The only problem was, they didn't know what she had said. And indeed, because she was still badly wounded, and Timothy's party didn't have a scratch on them, she certainly looked quite pitiable as she deliberately made herself smaller. It looked like something had happened inside Po's library, where Timothy and the others had brutally attacked Marigold and she barely escaped with her life.

At least, that was the story Timothy logically assumed had been told to everyone present.

Timothy cleared his throat. "Honestly, I was hoping for a shower and food, but if you insist, I'll tell you what happened from start to end."

And so he began to talk.

Timothy first told the people present about the mechanics of the Dungeon and how his group had only been inside for a week while ten months had passed inside Chrona. He

discussed the dungeon mechanics, the arrival in the Dark Forest, and the terrifying creatures that had been inside.

The crocodiles felt their blood boil with a hint of excitement as Timothy weaved a tale about the exciting and scary creatures in the Dungeon. Crocodiles were natural warriors, so the thought of fighting such powerful existences made them feel anticipation instead of fear. They imagined themselves fighting these Dark Stalkers rather than running away, like the cowardly Timothy did.

Eventually, Timothy got to the midpoint of the story, and that was when he noticed the crocodiles had started listening with more solemn expressions, as if trying to pick out any key details.

"You said her name was Sylphid." Remus interrupted at one point. "Graugh. How did you feel toward this... Emissary of the Dark Ones?"

Timothy blinked. "She was attractive, but I was with Marigold at the time and didn't put myself in any compromising situations."

Remus glanced at Marigold and raised his eyebrow, then he looked back at Timothy.

"Interesting."

That was all he said. The lack of a reaction made Timothy raise his guard internally. He'd already started to guess at what Marigold had told the others.

He continued his story. Eventually, he reached the part where Sylphid invited him into Cthulhu's Sanctum. This time, it was Blinker who interrupted.

"You idiot! Why would you go with her all by yourself?? She was an Emissary of the Dark Ones! You really expect us to believe you had no feelings for her after making a dumb decision like that?!"

Timothy's eyes dimmed, ever so slightly. "I had my reasons. It wasn't as if the others posed a threat to her even if they tagged along, and I didn't want to upset her or cause her to turn hostile."

Marigold's father snorted. "Doubtful! Thinking with your second head, it seems your feelings for her were not as platonic as you claimed!"

Timothy squinted his eyes a little. Was this the angle Marigold had gone? Saying Timothy betrayed Chrona because he fell in love with Sylphid and betrayed her? It was a

little far-fetched, and despite her father's blunt words, the other crocodiles still seemed to be on the fence. They weren't fully convinced yet.

Timothy continued the story. That was when something drastically changed in the atmosphere.

"You used your game powers to reverse her mental attack? Well played!" Blinker said. "You really taught that evil bitch a lesson! It seems Marigold wasn't being entirely forthcoming!"

"Well..." Timothy said, his heart slightly sinking. "That was until Faceless showed up. She and I had to combine our strengths to defeat him."

"Oh?" Remus asked, a strange expression on his face. "And how did you manage to do that?"

"Well, I quickly leveled up my eye powers and attacked him." Timothy explained. "First I attacked his mind to lower his guard, then I blasted him with Yredelemnul's Rage-
"

"Kyargh, there it is!!" Marigold suddenly screamed, interrupting Timothy and drawing everyone's attention to her. "I told you, daddy! That was the power of the Dark Ones he used! He didn't have that power until he went into the Sanctum with Sylphid, then when he came back out, he did! Doesn't that sound strange to you? To anyone else?!"

Timothy couldn't help but glare at Marigold. Her interruption came at the worst time.

Unfortunately, his glare was seen by the crocodiles, and that caused their thoughts to travel even further beyond what Marigold had just said.

"It all adds up!" Remus exclaimed. "We don't really know what happened after he entered Cthulhu's Sanctum. Look at the way he's speaking now! That Dark One must have corrupted him and secretly taken control of his mind, or maybe enslaved him. Are we really going to take his word on what happened in there?"

"Now, now hold on." Paimon interrupted. "You need to let Timothy finish. There's still more to the story."

[Indeed.] Raavul added. [Interrupting his story to create a false narrative is despicable behavior.]

Remus hesitated, then took a step back and nodded. "I think I speak for most when I say anything beyond this point should have all the details scoured. But yes, please

continue."

A few moments of silence followed. Timothy decided to continue telling the full truth, and so he detailed his attack on Faceless, the revelations about Cthulhu, and other such matters. He and Sylphid fled the sanctum, then they joined up with the others.

By the time Timothy got to the part where he fought and defeated Faceless a second time, the gazes of the crocodiles had shifted greatly from their starting points. It seemed the more Timothy explained, the more they distrusted him.

"That power is quite incredible." Remus said solemnly. "It sounds like it could even threaten my mother."

"Are you implying I would attack my aunt?" Timothy snipped back. "I'm not a servant of the Dark Ones. I just have this power because of my game abilities. It helped me get past their detection and ultimately fight our way out to escape. Without it, we'd all probably be dead, including Marigold."

Timothy continued a little further, and eventually he got to the point where his group exited the Dungeon, and Sylphid died. A faint look of sadness passed over his face, something all the crocodiles were easily able to see.

"Fool!" Blinker shouted. "I'm not buying this whole narrative about you being enslaved by the Dark Ones, but at this point even I can see you had feelings for Sylphid! Do you know what level of idiocy that entails? Those evil, evil monsters nearly wiped out my people! They're disgusting filth, and cannot be trusted in the slightest! How stupid were you to try and bring her back to Chrona?!"

"If he was enslaved or otherwise beguiled by the Dark One, it would explain a lot." Remus quickly pointed out. "Look at it this way, mother. Timothy is acting strangely, his words are different from before, he seemed to immediately fall in love with Sylphid right from the start, and that whole bit about her pledging to be his slave? Utterly ridiculous. It feels more like a play put on by the two of them to fool his companions. Why would she weaken herself before coming here? She clearly planned to use her superior strength to kill you and take out the rest of us, establishing a base of operations for the Dark Ones inside the Milky Way. We're lucky she died before she could come here!"

Blinker frowned. "Some of what you said makes a little sense, I guess... it all does feel a little too convenient."

"Convenient? It's the truth!" Paimon said. "The three of us will confirm it."

Blinker gave Paimon a strange look. "Paimon, you're Timothy's Pawn, yes? So if he gives you a direct order, you have to follow it."

"Well, yes, but Timothy's never done anything of the sort, aside from ordering me not to hurt his friends, which I wouldn't have done anyway." Paimon protested.

"And Ferral, you're Timothy's best friend, so you might cover for him in the event he was spinning a tall tale." Blinker added.

[If Timothy were truly beguiled by Sylphid, then he would not be Timothy anymore.] Ferral simply answered. [If my friend is not of sound mind, I would speak out against any lies he uttered.]

"So you say." Blinker replied. "And Raavul, you're Ferral's teacher, so it's also possible you would lie about Timothy for Ferral's sake."

[Preposterous.] Raavul flatly answered. [How poorly do you think of us Psions? We are warriors, not deceivers. I would not taint my honor by uttering falsehoods. It would cause my Psionic Seed to break apart if I went against my convictions.]

"I recall Demila was quite the deceiver." Blinker simply said.

Raavul didn't have a retort for that. Indeed, Demila had made it clear Psions could lie and deceive, just like any other species. It wasn't as if they were arbiters of morality, pure paladins of the light incapable of uttering falsehoods.

Timothy finished his story, detailing how Marigold attacked him. By this point, the looks of the crocodiles had firmly set in place. It seemed preposterous, the idea of Marigold brutally attacking Timothy out of nowhere. Why, because mere jealousy? Because she'd planned to steal Timothy's game powers all for herself? She had those powers before they entered the Dungeon. She could have easily left him without needing to go on the attack! Didn't it sound far less likely than Timothy and the others wanting to shut Marigold up before she could spill the beans?

Only Marigold's father flashed a faint look of dissatisfaction his daughter's way. He wasn't an idiot. He'd raised her from the moment her egg hatched, and he knew she wasn't exactly... the most *upright* crocodile.

But, even so. For her to attack Timothy and the others when she clearly held such deep affection for him and even let him take her virginity, it didn't seem likely she'd done the

things Timothy had claimed.

"Now that Timothy's done with his story," Fiona said, speaking for the first time in several minutes, "there do seem to be some important details missing you've all overlooked. Timothy is indeed acting differently from normal, but it's not because his mind was corrupted by the Dark Ones. It's because he's activated his Mind of Logic. He mentioned that at the end, though he didn't explain it well. It effectively disables his emotions and allows him to think purely logically."

Blinker's eyes lit up. "That's right, I trained Timothy and the others for two months. We practiced using Timothy's different Mind Modes, and the Mind of Logic is really useful for logical thinking and stuff. His Mind of Void was also used in that sanctum fight, and it had a great effect too."

"Assuming the sanctum fight happened as he described." Remus retorted. "Graugh! I find too many parts of his story unbelievable. I don't think we can trust his words anymore."

"Neither do I." Another crocodile chimed in.

"He's lying! Kyargh!" A different crocodile shouted.

Multiple voices chimed in. Before long, the situation became clear... Marigold's narrative had won out. None of the crocodiles trusted Timothy, and they were also looking at his three friends with a great deal of suspicion as well.

Timothy frowned, and Marigold smirked. She'd barely had to say anything since the impromptu trial started, but her efforts before his arrival had laid a firm groundwork.

"Oh?" Fiona eventually said, silencing the crowd. "And what exactly do you intend to do about it? Are you going to lock him up? Execute him? Because I know my son, and he's telling the truth. It's clear to me Marigold lied, and she wove this whole story to cover her tail."

"Ridiculous!" Marigold's father quickly replied. "Do you really expect us to believe your son was smitten on sight by that Dark One succubus and he was merely bringing her to Chrona despite knowing the risks... all because he simply fell in love with her? He already had a partner! At the very least, it shows a lack of morals and ethics for him to betray my daughter like that, but the most likely explanation is that some sort of mental trickery was cast on him! He's still defending Sylphid even now!"

Fiona groaned. That embarrassing episode with her son peeping on woman and girls across the galaxy had been buried, so only she and a few others knew her son could be quite lecherous. If anything, Fiona knew he definitely would have been gullible enough to fall for Sylphid's pretty face. Fiona had no idea what Sylphid looked like, but she could make a few guesses. Her son certainly wasn't *racist* and he stared like a dog at any remotely attractive female that entered his vision.

But this wasn't the time or the place to debate such things. Fiona was a little disappointed in her son for falling for the whims of a Dark One, but he was a young man, so he was bound to make mistakes. She could tell Sylphid's death and Marigold's attack had deeply hurt him. As his mother, it was her job to protect her little boy, so she walked over and stood beside him, putting her arm over his shoulder.

"Enough." Fiona finally said. "I can't force you all to change your minds. It's clear to me that Marigold has spun a web of lies, and you've fallen for her words. But I know my son, and he's not the person she's made him out to be. If you want to come after him, you'll have to go through me."

"And me!" Blinker said, as she flew over to Timothy's side. "You guys had better not try anything, or I'll beat your butts into the dirt!"

The crocodiles looked at their mother with apprehension. None of them were remotely strong enough to face her in battle, and even their warrior hearts wavered, knowing she could thrash ten of them silly without lifting a finger.

But just because Blinker was strong, that didn't mean she was their god. The crocodiles looked at their ancestor with great respect, but in this instance, they 'realized' she had been fooled by the young man. She was clearly too close to the situation, too attached to Timothy for her own good.

"Mother, please." Remus pleaded. "I know you are wise enough to see through the young man's lies. He went into that Sanctum with the Dark One alone and came out with her supposedly pledging to be his slave. Doesn't that strike you as odd? And what of his mastery of the Dark One's power? Does Yredelemnul's might not frighten you? If Timothy were to attack you when you weren't expecting it, he might badly injure or even kill you. You can't trust him!"

Blinker hesitated. "It's... it's true I hate the Dark Ones. All fairies do. But I'm telling you, that little hussy Marigold is lying! Even if I wouldn't trust Sylphid in the slightest,

she's dead, and Timothy is acting well within the bounds of what I've seen him do before. He's just talking this way because of his Mind Mode!"

Her words fell on deaf ears. The crocodiles wouldn't budge on distrusting Timothy, and Blinker's knowledge of the extra details only made it sound as if she was too invested in Timothy personally. Of course she would never turn against him, she still saw him as her cute little nephew, and not a villain lurking in the shadows, waiting to strike.

"Hurgh..." Kar eventually said, clearing his throat and drawing the gazes of everyone present. "Game Boy is a funny kid. Him falling for a cute Dark One is only to be expected. After all, he's a hot-blooded male! What male would not be interested in such a fine and mighty female? Of course, the matter of him cheating on my great-great-granddaughter is not good either. I choose to believe in Game Boy's version of the story, but I am still somewhat disappointed in the choices he made."

Another person spoke for the first time. It was Rebecca, who had not said a word since the impromptu trial began.

"I've known Timothy since he was born." Rebecca said plainly. "I find that his version of events is probably the most likely. However, I agree with the crocodiles here, in that the part where he entered the Sanctum is extremely suspicious. Too many coincidences lined up for him to obtain that power boost with his powers. It certainly is possible things happened just as he said, but if he truly did fall under the spell of Sylphid, perhaps as some sort of wicked plan by the Dark Ones to infiltrate the Milky Way, then I have to express my alarm here."

She continued. "I would place the possibility of the events inside Cthulhu's Sanctum happening as Timothy described at 40/60, with a 40% chance he's telling the complete truth, and a 60% chance he's omitted key details or heavily fabricated certain parts of the story. I lean more toward minor details being omitted, but I would be lying if I said Timothy's sudden attachment to the power of Yredelemnul didn't worry me. That alone gives me cause for concern."

Timothy gave Rebecca a long look. He had always seen her as another surrogate aunt, someone he could trust, but she was a lifeform almost as emotionless as the Psions. He never expected her to take a stance against him, but when she laid out the facts as presented, his story did feel difficult to believe. If even she felt this way, what of the crocodiles who didn't know him well?

Thus, a stalemate followed. Timothy didn't have a lot of people on his side, but the ones defending him were the leaders of Chrona, and Blinker was the strongest entity in the entire dimension. With her protecting him, the crocodiles wouldn't dare to make a move.

"How about this?" Rebecca eventually said. "I am a relatively neutral observer in this clash. I don't particularly care one way or the other whether Timothy is imprisoned or not, but I do care about the stability of Chrona. I will volunteer to keep a close eye on him over the coming period, and if he shows any signs of plotting against us, I will... take immediate action."

Her words caused Remus to shiver. She said it so matter-of-factly, his imagination ran wild. What sort of action would Rebecca take? He didn't know, and neither did the others. But since she was a cyborg, she must possess a lot of strength. She could probably suppress Timothy in an instant.

"That... sounds acceptable to me." Remus said. "Naturally, we crocodiles only fear that if he is unsupervised, Timothy might-"

BOOM!!!

Chrona suddenly shook as a powerful force struck it from somewhere unknown. Timothy's heart jumped. Everyone flinched and looked around, some more scared than others at the unexpected and violent interruption.

Several eyes fell on Timothy. The crocodiles immediately suspected he must behind this... attack! It had to be an attack!

Before anyone could voice their thoughts, the space just twenty feet away from Timothy distorted. A violent eruption of energy ripped Chrona's dimensional stability apart, revealing an ominous, sinister energy that poured into Chrona and made all the crocodiles pale with fright.

Nobody was more shocked than Timothy. He recognized the aura of that power immediately.

It belonged to Yredelemnul!

"What- what the fuck?!" Timothy shouted, his voice shaking. Even the Mind of Void couldn't suppress the emotions of shock and fear that seized his heart.

The energy quickly coalesced. Within seconds, it solidified into a pitch black swirling portal of darkness that grew until it was the size of two men stacked on top of and beside each other.

Everyone drew their weapons and pointed them at the portal. Seconds later, four armored figures leaped through wielding halberds forged from star-iron. These four figures flew out of the portal and stomped their feet on the ground, quickly surveying the situation and fanning out to point their weapons in every direction. They all appeared to be female, and they had dainty, beautiful butterfly-like wings on their back.

Blinker looked at them in surprise. "What? They're..."

Four more armored figures flew in, equipped with magical staves and shields, followed by four more equipped with greatbows. Finally, one last figure entered, someone with a powerful aura that rose to the same heights as Blinker herself. The figure's long white hair fell from behind her helmet. She swept her gaze around, then locked her attention on Timothy.

"It's him!" The figure shouted. "He's the one!"

Timothy took a step back as the armored warriors pointed their halberds, staves, and bows at him. A prickling sensation spread across Timothy's skin as he felt an acute sense of danger taking over his mind.

Death. He was about to die!

"Wait, wait!" Blinker shouted. "Fairy Queen Calanthra??"

The leading figure with the white hair paused, then turned her head to follow the source of the voice.

"Monster Queen Blinker?" Calanthra asked uncertainly. "What are you doing in this den of evil?"

Blniker was bewildered. "Den of evil? I don't understand. Please lower your weapons! Why are you threatening Timothy?"

"Timothy?" Calanthra shot back, turning to look at the fairly diminutive young man she had identified from before. "Is that what this creature calls itself? It's nothing more than a spawn of the Dark Ones! I traced the flow of Yredelemnul's power to this location. This must be Yredelemnul's Inheritor!"

The crocodiles looked at Calanthra with wide eyes, then they shot ferocious glares at Timothy.

So it was true! The little bastard was lying, and he nearly managed to escape! Luckily, the fairy queen herself arrived to execute him, saving their lives!

"No, no, what are you even saying?" Blinker asked, quickly teleporting in front of Timothy and raising her hands to create a barrier of energy. "This is a misunderstanding! Timothy is Jason Hiro's son! You've got it all wrong!"

"The Wordsmith?" Calanthra asked, her tone shifting slightly. "He's the Wordsmith's son?"

"Yes!" Blinker answered.

Calanthra narrowed her eyes. "Even if that's true... surely you can sense the aura of evil spewing from his body! He's been taken over by Yredelemnul! Don't defend the enemy of our people, Blinker! He'll backstab you before you know it!"

Like this, a standoff occurred as Blinker started to sweat. She had firmly been on Timothy's side before, but she had a deep respect for Calanthra. For her to appear here all of a sudden, could it be true? Was Timothy the creature she claimed him to be? A vile monster walking around in human skin?!

The fact Timothy was standing right behind Blinker suddenly made her even more nervous. What if Calanthra was right? It wasn't as if she had been lied to by Marigold as well. Calanthra was well-versed in the auras of the Dark Ones as well. If she said Timothy was one of them, what the hell kind of defense could she offer? Would Timothy attack her from behind, cutting her down with his eye-lasers due to her naivete?

Like this, the situation in Chrona reached a crisis point, putting everyone on edge.

Nobody knew what would happen next.

Part 757: Timothy's Tribulation

Far-Future Era. Late on Day 20, AJR. Pixiv.

Fairy Queen Calanthra was nervous, as were all the fairies on Pixiv. The galactic situation was worsening rapidly.

She had recently heard news of the Archangels and their plot to turn the False Cosmic Realm into a fortress for their twisted mutated creatures, the Kolvaxians. At the same time, she felt an ominous premonition regarding an ancient evil resurfacing on the world of Grimvolas, an ancient dragon empowering the Dolgrimites.

Both Wordsmiths were gone. Humanity was retreating into an ancient Cube to protect themselves.

The Volgrim Empire had suffered catastrophic losses due to the loss of 95% of their Psions. Their battle lines were failing rapidly.

The demons were working on a new plan to merge all their worlds together into a 100-lightyear super-cluster of stars. This would give them a better, though far from perfect assurance regarding their future defenses against the Kolvaxians.

By contrast, the fairies were in a terrible position. They had no Cosmics to protect them. As 'monsters', they were only lightly affiliated with the demons, but were not considered valuable enough to be targets for protection.

Thus, Calanthra had agreed to allow the humans to swallow the Pixiv star system into the Cube.

Normally, she would not want to do this, but the situation was worsening so rapidly in the Milky Way that with her senses, she could feel a terrible fate was coming for her people if she did not take immediate action to save them.

The good news was, fairies were extremely popular mating partners. There were fairies all across the galaxy. Even if Pixiv fell, their species wouldn't immediately go extinct. However, 99% of fairies were female, and they mostly gave birth to non-fairy children if they mated with non-fairy partners. This made them attractive targets for males of other species to wed, but it was a terrible value proposition for someone who wanted to ensure

the fairy lineage continued. All the male fairies were on Pixiv, and if they died off, it would truly be the end for their species, at least in the Milky Way.

There were more fairies hidden in other galaxies. Calanthra was certain of that much. The problem was, she had no idea how many there were or what their conditions were. The fairies had been cursed by Yredelemnul so they could never ascend into Cosmics. It was entirely likely that when they fled Andromeda to the other galaxies, they were captured and enslaved, turned into breeding partners for other wretched species around the universe.

If so, then that meant the Milky Way might be the last place remaining where fairies lived freely, able to continue their species in whatever limited capacity they could. It wasn't a glorious life, but it was comfortable, and it ensured their survival.

With all these thoughts in mind, Calanthra might not have been eager to join with the humans, but it was her best option at keeping the fairies relatively independent. The humans had a few rotten apples amidst the bunch, but most humans were decent people. Calanthra trusted the general collective, if not specific individuals.

Thus, when the morning arrived and Calanthra abruptly felt a cold chill descend across her entire body, she completely froze in place upon her throne, and her skin turned ghastly pale.

"What... what is this? The aura of a Dark One?! How has it appeared in this galaxy?!"

Calanthra didn't feel a powerful presence. In fact, it felt quite weak.

But she was intimately familiar with that sickening, horrid aura. It was a dead ringer for the enemy of all fairy-kind...

Yredelemnul.

Calanthra immediately formed a spiritual body and jumped off her seat, leaving her physical form in place. She rushed into the rear part of her palace, the secret area she had once shown Jason Hiro. In that courtyard, hidden behind layers upon layers of formations, there was a terrible and evil energy radiating in the air. She arrived before the Eye of Yredelemnul and shuddered. The Eye had always stared at her with cold hatred, a malice borne of instinctual bloodlust.

But now, it did not.

Yredelemnul seemed to be looking elsewhere. The Eye had a hungry gaze, a look of expectation. It could not speak or make noise, but its soul seemed to cry out in happiness, as if it had spotted a succulent treat.

"No..." Calanthra whispered, her heart as cold as ice. "You... an Inheritor?! That's impossible! Not a speck of your energy has ever leaked from here! How did you pass your power on, wretch?!"

The Eye ignored her. It continued to look in one particular direction, uncaring of her thoughts.

Calanthra did not hesitate. She immediately convened the other Fairy Queens and brought them into the secret area. Only these elites were allowed to know the existence of the abomination secreted away on Pixiv.

"Of course, First Queen." One of the other Fairy Queens said, after Calanthra explained the situation. "We will follow your lead. Are you able to pinpoint the Inheritor's position?"

"Ordinarily, I would not. But Yredelemnul has lost most of his intelligence and cunning. He has been fixedly gazing directly at the Inheritor's position. So long as we trace the Inheritor using the Eye's power, we will be able to spring a trap and kill him before he grows."

"The galaxy is quite vast..." Another Fairy Queen said worriedly. "To trace an exact position will be rather difficult."

"It will, but I have long controlled the majority of the Eye's power. I will find a way. You must all stay at my side and clad yourself with our finest weapons and armor. The Inheritor is quite weak right now, but we should still move quickly and strike before he can acquire allies and otherwise strengthen himself in any way."

"You're right. No sense in dilly-dallying." The other Fairy Queens agreed.

And so, Calanthra began her work. She spent a full hour using her magic to attempt to pinpoint the Inheritor.

However...

"The energy signature of the Inheritor is distressingly weak." Calanthra muttered. "It is so weak that it is like trying to detect the aura of an insect from ten kilometers in the

distance. If the Inheritor were stronger, the task would be easier. Their aura does feel a little stronger than when I first began looking for them, but it's still frustratingly faint."

"If they grow stronger, we will have a much more dangerous fight on our hands." The other Fairy Queen pointed out.

"True indeed." Calanthra concluded.

Several more minutes passed.

"I understand why the Inheritor is so difficult to pinpoint." Calanthra said eventually. "They are located outside of normalspace, inside a hidden dimension. There are extreme temporal distortions obfuscating the Inheritor's location. I'm making good headway, though. It shouldn't be long before- *what??*"

Calanthra stopped mid-sentence. She was utterly bewildered.

"The Inheritor's aura... vanished! It's gone! Don't tell me they died? Was it really that easy?"

Calanthra scrunched up her face. She squinted and looked up at Yredelemnul's Eye with deep suspicion. Could that bastard be planning something?

Yredelemnul continued to look in the general direction he had been looking for an hour now, but notably, his vision was less laser-focused on one spot. His pupil wavered slightly, as if searching for the Inheritor.

"He's lost track? Is this a deception? Did the Inheritor notice me and go into hiding? It would be terrible if that were the case!"

Calanthra was frustrated. She explained the situation to the other Fairy Queens.

"I suggest we wait here, just in case." One of the queens said. "Maybe the Inheritor will return. Once we're inside the Cube, we'll be in a time-accelerated domain. We'll have more time to search for him."

"I think the likelihood they've died is remote." Another queen added. "Let's just wait and see."

Calanthra agreed, and so they did. Calanthra continued to tap into the Eye's power, and after a few hours, she made a discovery.

"The Inheritor isn't dead. He or she seems to have obscured their power through some unknown method. I can still sense a faint trail of energy leading back to the Eye. We will

continue to wait until the Cube has arrived to swallow the Pixiv system. We'll stop until the merging is complete, then resume work afterward."

Like this, several hours passed.

The midday sun lowered down the horizon. Night began to approach, and then the sun dipped below the horizon.

"The Cube will arrive here within six hours." One of the Fairy Queens said. "I received word that the Sharmur system was successfully ingested. Melody still possesses her full powers, which means demons can keep their strength even if their Cosmic power has become planet-bound."

"A fortuitous revelation." Calanthra acknowledged. "It's a shame, but I do not think the Inheritor will resurface before the Cube arrives. It seems he hid himself when he sensed my aura searching for his. He is truly cunning, like his *predecessor*."

Calanthra looked at Yredelemnul in disgust. Yredelemnul was known as an extremely intelligent Dark One, skilled in manipulation and political ploys. His eye-abilities were frighteningly powerful, but his methods for dominating and influencing the minds of others were his scariest features. He had even caused many powerful Apex Cosmic fairies to turn against their sisters when Yredelemnul invaded.

In the end, the fairies killed him and stole one of his eyes for themselves. It was a catastrophic final battle that resulted in the death of their Ruler, The Timeless. Even though Yredelemnul also died, Andromeda had been reduced to ruins, and the remaining Dark One Cosmics were more than a match for the fairies.

Calanthra's mother died after their flight to the Milky Way. Her passing was a scar on Calanthra's heart which had never fully healed. Calanthra hated Yredelemnul from the bottom of her heart, but she couldn't bring herself to destroy his Eye. It was a final weapon the fairies could use if the situation turned truly dire.

But as for his Inheritor?

That rat bastard would die without a doubt if she could just wrap her nails around his neck. Calanthra would be ecstatic if she could frustrate Yredelemnul's plans in such a way. The look in his eye would be completely worth it, even if he was too mindless now to understand what his Inheritor's death meant.

Calanthra hummed to herself as the pleasant thought of screwing over Yredelemnul came and went. All of a sudden, the Eye became violently agitated, and that feeling of dread from earlier washed over all the Fairy Queens once again.

This time, the sensation was tens of times stronger!

Calanthra's heart sank. Yredelemnul's Inheritor had returned, but this time his aura was so much more powerful that she was easily able to lock on to his exact location in seconds.

"H-how did he strengthen so much, so fast?!" One of the other Fairy Queens cried out in horror. "We have to attack now! Strike while the iron is hot!"

"Yes we do." Calanthra said grimly. "Ready yourselves! I'm opening a portal now!"

The pool of Cosmic Blood beneath Yredelemnul's Eye began to violently boil, tearing open a portal to the location of his Inheritor. At once, the fairies dove inside, ready for battle.

They had no time to waste.

* * *

"Blinker, watch out! Don't let that creature backstab you! Whoever Timothy was before, he cannot be trusted now!" Calanthra shrieked, beside herself with worry.

Blinker wasn't any ordinary Fairy Queen. In the past, she had been one of Calanthra's lesser Queens, but now she was also the Monster Queen, and stood on equal terms with Calanthra. As the First Queen, Calanthra had no other peers, so she valued Blinker's life highly. She was terrified that she was about to watch her sister die!

Timothy took two steps back and held up his hands.

"Uh, Calanthra? Hello. I'm Timothy. I'm not... Yredelemnul. I'm not his Inheritor. Not exactly, anyway..."

"SILENCE!" Calanthra shouted, her eyes turning bloodshot as she pointed a magical staff at Timothy. "Filthy wretch. Your very breath is tainted with evil! Do not think your lies will be able to shake my mind, no matter how well your act of playing the fool might deceive the others! I am well acquainted with His power!"

Timothy scrunched up his face. The situation was getting more and more distressing every second. Emotionally, he wasn't scared of what was about to happen, but logically,

he understood that the odds of getting out of this unscathed were plummeting by the second.

Blinker was worried at first, but she quickly steeled her resolve. She trusted Calanthra, but she trusted Timothy too. She knew how Timothy's game power worked. She had personally trained him in using his Mind Modes. Right now, he was acting exactly as he would if he were in the Mind of Logic. Calm, rational, controlled, mostly emotionless.

He wasn't possessed by a demon or an evil Ruler. Thus, Blinker firmed up her convictions and chose to trust him. Her back was exposed. If he wanted to kill her, he might even be able to do so. But she chose to trust him anyway, because that was who she was.

"Calanthra." Blinker said, her tone serious. She strengthened the barrier to protect herself and Timothy. "You're making a mistake. I know why you're scared. But you don't know the full situation. It's not what you think, and if you attack Timothy, if you hurt him, and especially if you kill him, you'll truly regret your actions later."

Calanthra narrowed her eyes. "You're threatening me, Blinker? Has that darkspawn corrupted your mind?"

"I wasn't speaking a threat, in the sense that 'I' would make you regret killing him." Blinker patiently explained. "I'm saying once you realize who you'd killed, you would feel a sense of regret I can't even put into words. Timothy is the galaxy's greatest hope now that both Wordsmiths are dead. If you kill him, you'll be committing a crime against all free-spirited life."

Calanthra's fierce gaze lightened, at least a little. "So you're saying this boy isn't a servant of evil? How can you know, when you are incapable of sensing the mountain of atrocities radiating from his soul? Even just looking at him makes me want to wretch!"

"It's true... I can't properly sense Yredelemnul's aura." Blinker answered. "But I don't think the situation is what you imagine. What exactly do you think Timothy is?"

"He's Yredelemnul's Inheritor, obviously!" Calanthra exclaimed. "What else could he be?"

As before, her words caused the crocodiles to harden their gazes even further toward Timothy. With everything they'd heard today, they would truly be idiots if they trusted

this villain even the slightest bit. It was obvious Blinker was blinded by her attachments to the boy. She was going to cause the death of all of them!

A moment of silence followed.

Blinker slowly lowered her palms. She stood up straight and weakened the barrier around herself and Timothy.

"Calanthra. Lower your weapons, please." Blinker said. "Timothy is clearly rational and capable of speaking. Why don't you let him, myself, and his mother explain the situation?"

Calanthra gripped her staff tighter. Now that Blinker had weakened the barrier, if she were to rush forward, Calanthra could probably kill the boy on the spot! Before he even had a chance to react she could...

She could...

Calanthra hesitated. She had known Blinker a long time. They weren't best friends by any means, but they were more than acquaintances. Blinker was a free spirit who had mated her way up the totem pole. She was Calanthra's peer, her equal.

Calanthra didn't want to tear apart their relations and rip Blinker's face off. The boy wasn't making any hostile moves. Might Blinker possess some knowledge capable of altering Calanthra's perception of the situation?

Thus, Calanthra carefully took a step back. She slowly retracted her staff and gestured with her chin to the other Fairy Queens.

They didn't lower their guards, but they did stop directly pointing all their weapons at Timothy. It was a good sign.

"Start talking." Calanthra ordered. "Speak your piece. It had better be good. I'm going to need a lot of convincing."

"Thank you." Blinker said, fully lowering the barrier. She did not step away from Timothy's side, and in truth, she was fully on alert for any attacks to come his way. She trusted that Calanthra would not make any moves, but as for the crocodiles... they were still obviously violently hostile, and rather brutish, to boot. Who knew if that little vixen Marigold wouldn't whisper some words to get a 'brave savior' to sneak attack Timothy while Blinker's attention was elsewhere?

Blinker was the matriarch of the crocodile species. But, clearly, she did not possess a status equal to gods in their eyes. After today, she realized that her descendants were not looking at her with the same respect as her direct children did.

That revelation made her uncomfortable, but it also went to show that they were becoming a lot more independent over time. Even she had no idea how they would evolve as a society moving forward.

"It's like this," Blinker explained. "Twelve months ago, Timothy acquired his Heroic Power. It gave him the power of 'video games'. He can level up, and-"

"Vid-eyeo gaymz?" Calanthra repeated, bewildered. "Level up? These terms are..."

Blinker wrinkled her nose. She had tried explaining the concepts to the crocodiles before, but the majority of them didn't understand, either. Those who had not played games would have a very, very, very hard time comprehending them.

At that moment, Ferral levitated forward. [Queen Blinker. I have something to say.]

The young Psion bowed his head slightly toward Calanthra in a show of respect.

[Queen Calanthra. Allow me to transmit a Memory Fragment into your mind. It will allow you to quickly understand the concepts behind Timothy's powers.]

Memory Transfer was actually a fairly advanced Psionic ability, but Ferral had acquired it from a Lootbox at some point, and while he hadn't had much use for it, this turned out to be the perfect opportunity to make use of his niche ability.

Calanthra didn't hesitate. It seemed Timothy's power would be utterly incomprehensible to her, based on Blinker's strange words, so she opted to nod toward Ferral. He levitated toward her, held out his finger, and pressed a tiny sphere of light against her forehead. The other Fairy Queens tensed up, worried this might be a sneak attack on the First Queen, but Calanthra had no such qualms.

Ferral was laughably weak in her eyes. Even a 5th Level Psion might not be her match, let alone a 2nd or 3rd Level Psion. If this psionic bead could hurt her spiritual body, she might as well just call it quits and retire, passing the position of First Fairy Queen to the next in line. She would be too embarrassed to keep on living in the mortal realm after such a loss.

Thus, she accepted Ferral's gift. The memory fragment contained many of Ferral's direct observations of Timothy, as well as his full memory of the events which took place

in the Dark Forest, their training with Blinker, and many other such things.

The moment Calanthra took the memory bead, Ferral's body sagged a little, and he became visibly exhausted. It took a lot out of his mental acuity and made him feel as if he had been speaking and thinking nonstop for days at a time. The result was worth it though, as Calanthra sank into fifteen minutes of complete silence. She closed her eyes and pondered on the events depicted inside Ferral's memories.

Naturally, Ferral could have altered the memories to make Timothy look better, but Calanthra wasn't just receiving an audio/video recording. This memory bead contained countless thoughts, emotions, even recollections of scents and intuition points during the events depicted. It was as if she had experienced the Dark Forest dungeon along with the others.

The crocodiles waited impatiently, Timothy and the others stood with bated breath.

Eventually, Calanthra opened her eyes. Her expression was greatly eased.

"I see. I have reviewed Ferral's memory fragment. I now understand Timothy's abilities much more clearly."

She gave Timothy a long look. The hostility in her eyes was not gone. Even Ferral's memories were incapable of dissipating her rage and hatred toward anything related to the murderer of her mother and the powerhouses of her species. But Calanthra was able to examine the situation with far more objectivity than before.

"You obtained the power of Yredelemnul right when your Heroic Abilities awakened?" Calanthra asked.

Timothy nodded slowly. "Yes. It was one of my basic abilities."

"Blinker. You knew of the ability, as did Fiona. Did neither of you caution him against strengthening it?" Calanthra asked, glancing from Blinker, still in front of Timothy, to Fiona, who was beside her son, an arm still draped over his shoulder protectively.

"I did, but it didn't seem to have any control over his mind, and after using the game abilities myself, I determined the Eye power was being used in a purely utilitarian manner." Fiona explained.

"Honestly, I didn't even know what Yredelemnul was until Fiona told me about it..." Blinker said slowly. "I also didn't see it as anything more than his game power manifesting."

"That is my fault." Calanthra said, her tone solemn. "I should have inducted you into our people's secrets long ago. If you had understood the terror of that ancient Dark One, you would have prevented Timothy from awakening its power further."

Calanthra nibbled her lips. She was uncertain now. Timothy wasn't cackling maniacally, or looking at her with contempt, or doing anything else she could interpret as evil. He looked completely normal, though also emotionless due to his Mind Mode. If it weren't for the frighteningly potent aura wafting off his body, she would be just as in the dark as the others.

Those who were not familiar with the Dark Ones, but who did possess keen senses, would only be able to determine that Timothy had a strong aura around his body; they would not know who it actually belonged to, and likely wouldn't see it as 'evil'. It was only because Calanthra was so intimately familiar with Yredelemnul that she felt an intense loathing and disgust toward the young man.

"Alright." Calanthra said. "You strengthened Yredelemnul's power. How mighty has it become? Can you reduce its strength?"

"I can't de-level my abilities." Timothy answered. "What I've leveled will stay with me forever."

"Mmm..." Calanthra mumbled. "I want to believe you. I want to believe you're a good person and this is all a misunderstanding. But Ferral's memories also included the entire discussion up to the moment of my arrival. It seems like there are a lot of mysteries around your entry into Cthulhu's Chamber. You claim your mind was not subverted by Sylphid, but do we have any evidence you're telling the truth?"

Timothy faltered. "I... I don't know, Calanthra. I've explained my side of the story many times, but nobody believes me. Marigold started this whole trial by lying about what happened inside the Dungeon. Now it seems nobody will believe me even if I claim otherwise."

Calanthra slowly looked over at Marigold. She knew who this crocodile was, because Marigold was *also* inside Ferral's memories, including her brutal assault on Timothy.

"If Timothy were the monster you claimed, I would be quite pleased by your quick thinking." Calanthra said, causing Marigold to smile slightly.

"Unfortunately, I also know the *real* reason you attacked him inside Po's Library," Calanthra added right afterward, causing Marigold's scales to turn a sickly pale color. "You are quite the selfish vixen, aren't you? I almost respect your cunning, little scaled girl."

"What are you saying about Marigold?" Marigold's father chuffed, puffing out his chest. "Watch yourself! I don't care if you're a Fairy Queen or not! Don't slander my daughter! You only know one side of the story!"

Blinker gave him a weird look. Did he not understand that Calanthra alone was Blinker's equal in power, and the other Fairy Queens could rip him apart with similar ease? If he wanted to dig a grave for himself, Blinker wasn't about to stop him.

"I am not entirely convinced about Timothy's goodness, but I am certainly convinced regarding your precious daughter's malice." Calanthra said blandly. "You should speak less so that others will not see you as a fool."

Seeing that Calanthra had come around quite a bit on Timothy, Fiona seemed to make up her mind about something.

"Rebecca, are you done yet?" Fiona asked, looking over at the cyborg who had maintained her distance from Timothy, and from the Crocodiles as well. Unlike Fiona, Rebecca had not walked over to Timothy's side, and had stayed behind with Kar.

Rebecca nodded. "I finished three minutes and twenty-six seconds ago. I was wondering when you would bring it up."

"Huh?" Timothy asked, turning to look at his mother's side profile. "Finished what?"

Fiona smiled at her son.

"Analyzing the footage from the Dark Forest, of course. Previously, we only had Marigold's T-REX to work with, and it was missing crucial parts of the narrative. We knew she was lying about the last part of the journey, the fight inside the Library, but we didn't know if her reasons for lying were as simple as what she stated. We wanted to wait for you and the others to come out before we made a judgment call. Unfortunately, Marigold blew the whole matter up and created quite a storm of lies among the crocodiles."

Timothy's jaw slackened.

"The T-REXes... they record footage! How could I forget? Mom, do you have the recording of what happened in the Sanctum?"

"We do," Fiona said, "but this whole trial started so fast we didn't have time to analyze it. I could only entrust the matter to Rebecca. She's been scouring the footage with her internal processors this whole time. I planned to take you into custody, then to analyze the footage myself and reveal it to the crocodiles afterward, but since Calanthra arrived... we'll have to make do with the raw video."

Marigold's already pale scales seemed to shrivel up at Fiona's words.

"W-what are you saying?!" Marigold asked. "You're forging evidence to protect Timothy?!"

Fiona scowled at her. "Watch your mouth, brat. I've known since the beginning about your brutal attack on my son. The only reason I didn't say anything was because I wanted to know for sure if he'd been taken over by a Dark One, and now I'm about to find out, just like everyone else."

Fiona hadn't had time to analyze the footage from Timothy's T-REX. Nobody had; only Rebecca. Thus, her assistance was going to be crucial for this part.

Rebecca revealed a small projection device she'd been keeping hidden in her grasp the whole time. She pulled a small cable out of her wrist, then attached it to the device.

With this, a holographic display appeared in the air above everyone's heads, drawing their eyes to it. Rebecca projected the events of the Dungeon in chronological order. She cycled through different POVs of the five T-REX users, including Timothy, Marigold, Paimon, and both Psions.

The Psions were surprised. Ferral was familiar with video games, but he was no Technopath. He wasn't familiar with the intricacies of the T-REX, and Raavul was even more ignorant. They had no idea the suits could record everything in a 360 degree radius around them using smart metal, vibrations within the environment, and so on.

For the first time, everyone, including Marigold, got a good look at what exactly happened inside Cthulhu's Sanctum. Calanthra's face was dark as the night, seeing the thriving community of Dark Ones. She understood that Timothy had traveled there via a 'dungeon', but she wasn't certain about how such a system functioned.

Had Timothy really traveled across galaxies to a Dark One's enclave? Was it a false world, simulated by a higher power? A reproduction? Could it have been a form of time travel? Something else entirely?

She didn't know. Nobody present did.

The fairies, the crocodiles, and Timothy's friends watched as everything played out just like he had described. Sylphid attacked him, pinned him down, and attempted to steal Yredelemnul's Shard from him. Timothy fought her off, then he unleashed the power of Yredelemnul's Eye against Faceless. Sylphid submitted to Timothy, and all was made clear.

Several crocodiles frowned deeply. They looked at Marigold, understanding now that her version of events was... inaccurate, to say the least.

"Marigold." Kar said, directing a look of disappointment at his descendant. "Hurgh. Anything to say for yourself?"

"It's... fake!" Marigold spat. "Rebecca and Blinker planned this! They're using fairy magic to fake these images!"

"What feeble lies." Calanthra said, her disapproval of Marigold rising further. "These videos are clearly based on technological principles, not magical ones. My people are incapable of creating them."

Marigold pointed an accusatory finger at Blinker. "You're working with Fiona to protect him! This is all a plot against me!"

"Yes!" Marigold's father quickly chimed in. "Brothers, sisters, don't be fooled! All is not as it seems! Wasn't Rebecca standing against Timothy earlier? Now she reveals she was actually on his side the whole time! She's already lied once, clearly she's manipulating these false memories to deceive us!"

The expressions on the faces of several crocodiles changed. They carefully took a few steps away from Marigold and her immediate family.

Remus, Marigold's great grandfather, shook his head and sighed.

"Graugh. What a farce. Rebecca, please show us the final battle involving Timothy and Marigold."

Rebecca nodded. It didn't take long for her to show multiple angles of that final fight, revealing just how violently Marigold had brutalized her companions. Even her father was

shocked by her behavior.

For the first time, Marigold's father took a step away from his daughter and looked at her as if she were possessed by an alien mind-virus. Since when had his cute little girl turned so despicable? He assumed from the beginning that she had fudged the truth a little, but these videos completely flipped the narrative!

"Marigold, graugh! You..."

Marigold started to shake. All eyes were on her now. If it hadn't been for those recordings, she was sure she could have maintained a fearless attitude and stayed safe from any consequences! But unfortunately, she had played her cards before the final hand, and now she was short on chips.

"D-daddy..." Marigold whimpered, looking him right in the eyes. "They're fake... those videos are fake. You believe me, right?"

Her father's expression softened. At once, he returned to her side, then looked at the others.

"Of course I believe you! I can't believe my conviction wavered. Graugh! You lot, bullying my innocent little girl, can't you see she's suffered enough already?!"

Timothy raised an eyebrow. So did the others.

Her father was about to turn on her. It was the final nail in Marigold's coffin. Why did he suddenly change his mind?

"Sneaky." Paimon suddenly said. "Marigold... did you just use your *Charm* ability on your own father to turn him back to your side? Even as a Demon, I'm in awe of your shamelessness."

Marigold flinched. She shot a nasty glare Paimon's way. "Shut up, you nasty bloodskin, don't just shout accusations randomly!"

"In terms of accusations, I could never come close to the nerve you've shown." Paimon retorted, his tone bland. "Is there anything left that's worth saying?"

Undoubtedly, Marigold was finished. Her entire plot had fallen apart, and she'd landed flat on her face in front of everyone. She'd even been forced to Charm her own father to no avail.

Timothy had no idea how her Charm spell worked. The Eye of Yredelemnul could only see the names of skills, not how they worked, but it seemed likely that if others knew she could use such an ability, its effectiveness would drop drastically.

Privately, Timothy wondered again if Marigold had used Charm on him without his knowledge. The thought she might have mind-raped him was sickening to say the least.

After the vibe inside Chrona had shifted, Fiona pulled away from Timothy and turned to face Marigold directly.

"Assaulting my son was one thing. If it had just been that, I would have had you jailed for several years to teach you a lesson. But the real problem is that you lied multiple times, spread malicious rumors, and did everything you could to bring harm to Timothy and the others. Timothy faced the possibility of being imprisoned or even executed because of you. Calanthra alone might have killed him if we hadn't exposed your plot."

"For that reason," Fiona continued, "I'm going to cast judgment now on you. I will have you imprisoned in a special cell for a hundred years. Like all crocodiles, you're immortal, so you won't die in there, and I aim to do everything I can to rehabilitate you, but if that proves impossible, then you can stay in there forever."

"You're going to imprison me?!" Marigold asked in a panic. "Th-this is unfair! You can't do that!"

"Oh, but I can." Fiona said ominously.

Fiona waved her hand. A formless pressure erupted from her body and spread out into the skies. Timothy's sharp eyes detected tiny tethers of electrical energy that fired out in all directions, imperceptible to ordinary eyes. Not just him, but the fairies and the Psions also detected these tethers, albeit to varying degrees.

From all directions, tiny spherical drones swarmed downward. Marigold's body tensed as an army of tiny orbs rushed toward her with malicious intent.

"W-what are you doing?!" Marigold shrieked.

She reached into her Inventory and pulled out the Thunder Gauntlets, equipped them in an instant, and swung her fists up at the descending swarm.

Nothing happened. The power of the Thunder Gauntlets failed to activate. Marigold had intended to send a shockwave out, blasting apart the drones, but to her horror, the gauntlets seemed to have been stopped by an unknown power. In her haste, she had

overlooked the fact that Fiona was the one who helped Jason design these gauntlets. There was no chance she would let the young crocodile escape while using them.

Seconds later, the drones crashed against Marigold's scales and exploded into a sticky tree-sap-like substance that rapidly engulfed her figure, hardened, and pinned her in place.

"Daddy, daddy!!" Marigold screeched, as the drones grabbed onto her solidified form, then began lifting her into the air. In front of everyone's eyes, Marigold was flown off to an unknown place, vanishing from their sight within moments.

The field went still.

Timothy gave his mother a look of appreciation. He had underestimated her and Rebecca. Obviously, they must have suspected something was fishy from the very start. They knew Timothy too well to think he'd really been taken over by a dark god, but they did have to also consider the possibility Marigold was telling the truth. They bided their time, and eventually forced the truth out in front of everyone.

Now, Timothy was cleared on all charges. He was not a slave to the Dark Ones, he had not betrayed humanity, and he had not betrayed Chrona either.

With all that said, there was only one last matter that hadn't been dealt with.

"I still don't know if Timothy can be fully trusted." Calanthra said. "You don't know the power of the Dark Ones. We need to make sure your son is still fully in control of his mind and will remain that way."

Fiona nodded. "Do what you need to do, Calanthra. I don't want him to turn into a megalomaniac any more than you do."

"So be it." Calanthra answered.

Part 758: Mind Breaker

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy had succeeded beyond all odds. He'd survived the Dungeon, he'd grown far stronger than when he went in, and he had endured through serious trials and tribulations, including two near death experiences with women he was attracted to. Life was funny like that.

But it hadn't all been good. Timothy's relationship with Marigold was over and buried eight feet beneath the soil. Sylphid was dead. He was a young man, only eighteen, and he'd suffered two serious blows to his heart. If he hadn't switched to the Mind of Logic, he would have likely broken down in tears and gone into catatonia for a while.

Instead, Timothy gave off the false impression to those who didn't know him very well that he was utterly unmoved by all the events that had just transpired.

Sylphid's death? Whatever.

The power of Yredelemnul? Whatever.

Marigold's imprisonment? Whatever.

He seemed rather blasé about his experience in the Dungeon. Only a few people who truly knew him well, along with his teammates who had seen him breaking down right before he activated the Mind of Void, understood that he was far, far from stable right now.

Timothy's emotions had been reduced by 95%, but those emotions were so painful and extreme that even now, there was a sense of failure, depression, and anguish nibbling at the back of Timothy's mind. Timothy might appear emotionless on the surface, but even his logical mind couldn't stop replaying the images of Sylphid's death over and over, forcing him to fixate on her pain before she died.

It was a form of self-inflicted torture, one Timothy did not mention to anyone else.

* * *

"Demonstrate to me how your power works." Calanthra ordered, standing before Timothy with an imposing attitude. She conjured a phantasmal life-form made of spiritual energy, a replication of herself. "Strike it with all your power."

Timothy shook his head. "All my power? That won't be necessary."

The projection Calanthra had made was formidable. Timothy could tell Calanthra herself was about on par with Blinker, as were all the other Fairy Queens present. But Blinker was only at the level of a Demon Emperor, and Faceless had been at the level of a Demon Overlord, much stronger than all of them in terms of physical might.

Timothy realized that he had grown much more powerful in the dungeon, to the point he was now an extremely dangerous life-form within the confines of Chrona.

A second later, Timothy's eyes radiated a red light as he directed his focused attention toward the spiritual entity Calanthra had conjured.

ZOT!

A screeching noise rang out in the air as Timothy easily blasted apart the projection Calanthra had formed. His eye-lasers punched a hole through its chest and slammed into the ground behind the doll, blasting hundreds of kilograms of soil outward in a cone, making the crocodiles nearby raise their claws to shield their faces as clods of dirt and pebbles sprayed their bodies.

A few seconds later, it was all over. Calanthra's expression turned ugly.

"You have progressed Yredelemnul's power quickly in such a short period of time." Calanthra said, her tone heavy. "Curiously, I did not sense any inherent rage or malice behind your attack. You appeared the same as before. Yredelemnul's power should require one to focus their hatred and malice to achieve the most powerful effects."

"That's not quite right." Timothy said, correcting Calanthra. "Yredelemnul's power does not revolve around negative emotions, but instead mental focus. The more concentrated and focused my thoughts, the mightier the effects."

"You think to correct me, someone who has been monitoring and manipulating Yredelemnul's power for millions of years?!" Calanthra spat, directing an aggrieved look Timothy's way. "I think I know Yredelemnul better than you do!"

"You said I was his Inheritor." Timothy replied mildly. "Don't you only control his eye by using fairy magic as a medium? I control his power directly. Within myself. Maybe I do know more about it than you."

He continued. "You said hatred and malice are what empower Yredelemnul. Try changing your viewpoint. Hatred is the counterpart to love. Whether you love or hate

someone, you will likely focus intense emotions toward them. Unlike Apathy, which involves a lack of focus and interest, hatred and love grant enough focus to become potent stabilizing forces with Yredelemnul's power. Thus, he likely used them because those were easy emotions for him to latch onto."

Timothy shrugged. "I don't particularly have much hatred in my heart. But through my powers, I can gain remarkable mental focus via other means. Thus, I do not *need* to tap into hatred to amplify Yredelemnul's strengths."

Calanthra lifted her hand to stroke her chin. Her anger faded as she looked away and nodded along to Timothy's words. He was making a lot of sense.

Calanthra had 'owned' the Eye of Yredelemnul for millions of years, long before even the Volgrim came into existence. However, the truth was that she had always been fearful to use it, only tapping into it sparingly to travel or send expeditions into Ripspace. She might have been around it for a long, long time, but she was always terrified of accidentally corrupting her mind or causing a catastrophe.

Timothy, on the other hand, tapped into Yredelemnul's power through a different means, and he started off unaware of who Yredelemnul truly was. He was untainted by the fear of Yredelemnul that Calanthra bore, and as such he simply treated the Dark One's power like a tool to be used at his discretion.

This was, for obvious reasons, an alarming value proposition. But without fear tainting his every move, Timothy had analyzed the power and figured out new ways it could function. Calanthra privately wondered if she could use this new information to fundamentally alter the Eye she owned on Pixiv. Could she reduce its vile aura, making it more a weapon for good? Or were her thoughts turning ominous now, slowly bringing forth a future catastrophe upon Pixiv?

Meanwhile, Blinker and Fiona were listening to Timothy's words, as were Rebecca, Kar, and all the other crocodiles.

For now, they were merely observers. Fiona felt that her son hadn't become a monster, but when it came to the evil of Yredelemnul, Jason had pressed upon her mind the simple fact that he thought Calanthra's secret weapon was extremely frightening and dangerous. How could Fiona rest easily knowing her son had come back from the damned Dungeon having empowered the Eye so casually without thinking through the consequences?

She was worried sick!

The crocodiles, having witnessed Timothy's eye powers in person, now looked at him more warily.

Something which couldn't be understated was that only a small, small portion of the crocodiles in Chrona had followed Marigold to witness Timothy's impromptu trial. Perhaps only 5% of Chrona's crocodiles, in total. They ultimately ended up being the ones who were most directly related to Marigold, including her nearest relatives, her gandparents, and especially Remus, the seventh child of Blinker and Kar, who was also Marigold's great-grandfather.

Thus, the crocodiles here were not happy about Marigold's imprisonment. They had to admit that she had committed serious crimes, but they felt the whole matter was handwaved away a little too fast for Timothy's benefit. One couldn't help but wonder how much Timothy's mother, the leader of Chrona, was playing favorites by immediately sentencing Marigold to a hundred years of imprisonment.

Naturally, these things would not be spoken out loud. The crocodiles swallowed their resentment and paid attention to what was going on now. Seeing that Timothy had grown so explosively in power, the crocodiles felt their warrior blood stirring. They wanted to fight him!

The problem was, Calanthra was a fairy queen, like Blinker. The crocs weren't the smartest group in the galaxy, but even they could theorize she must be roughly equivalent to their own ancestor, Blinker. And Timothy just shot a hole through her magic??

Wasn't he a little too absurdly overpowered now?!

They decided to tactfully keep their mouths shut. Calanthra spent more time talking to Timothy about his powers before eventually coming to a new decision.

"You also have the ability to dominate the minds of other sentients." Calanthra observed. "I want you to attack me with that power."

Timothy raised an eyebrow. "Absolutely not."

"You refuse?" Calanthra asked.

"I do." Timothy answered. "Yredelemnul's Disdain caused even a creature at the peak of the mortal realm to become a drooling, mindbroken mess. He cowered in terror and nearly pissed himself. You are... weaker than Faceless was. I wouldn't want to use such a power on someone who isn't my enemy."

Calanthra bristled slightly at Timothy's words. "It's true the fairies had fallen from our heights, but of all the fairies here, I am most familiar with Yredelemnul's power. I have been exposed to his energy the longest. I am most resistant to his power. Additionally, this is not my true body, but merely a projection of my spirit infused with my will. Mind-searing powers will have lessened effects compared to using them on my true body."

Timothy fell silent. He didn't say anything for ten long seconds as he analyzed her words.

"...Alright. I'll do it, under the condition that you *really* firm up your mind first. Don't treat this casually. It's not a game."

Seeing that the young man was deeply concerned for her well-being, Calanthra felt momentarily touched. If he really was Yredelemnul's Inheritor, the fact he had such a kind heart innately felt as though he might find a way to use the power in a good way. Far better than some megalomaniacal villain obtaining it and turning it against the free peoples of the universe.

Calanthra quickly activated her full fairy magic and shielded her mind. She spent thirty long seconds preparing for Timothy's attack.

After squatting down and looking at Timothy with a look of serious intent, Calanthra nodded.

"Do it."

Timothy still hesitated.

I shouldn't go at her with my full power. Timothy thought. *The Mind of Logic gives me incredible mental focus with zero distracting thoughts. It's too dangerous to strike her with my full power. I'll use... half my focus. Half my thoughts will be thinking about Sylphid, and the other half...*

Timothy's eyes suddenly turned dark purple. An overwhelming force erupted in his mind, swept outward, and tore through Calanthra's mental defenses in an instant.

"**SUBMIT TO ME.**" Timothy's voice boomed in Calanthra's mind.

Instantly, Calanthra's skin paled. Sweat broke out across her entire body, and all the strength vanished from her legs. She fell to her knees. Calanthra opened her mouth to let out a horrible scream, a wail of terror, but no words came out.

Memories replayed. She recalled the day her mother died. She recalled the funeral. She remembered the pain and torment she suffered, having to try and rebuild the future of fairykind with only three male fairies left to repopulate their people. She remembered arriving in a hostile galaxy with no idea what to expect, danger lurking in every star system.

Calanthra screamed, but no words came out. All her interactions with Yredelemnul's Eye had not prepared her for this moment. It was like a deity from the Cosmic Realm had torn through the Firmament and grabbed her, drowning her thoughts in darkness.

In an instant, Timothy's presence seemed to grow in magnitude, swallowing the sky. His presence exploded with brilliant golden light, searing her retinas. He was like a god towering above her, making her shiver and shake with fear and longing.

She wanted to worship him. She had to worship him!

Calanthra flopped forward onto the ground and threw out her arms, prostrating herself while quietly sobbing under her breath.

"...orgive... me... lord... didn't mean... question... greatness... hic..."

Timothy appeared visibly unmoved, but even he was shocked. He had deliberately dialed down his power, yet this was the result? How the hell had Calanthra become mindbroken? She seemed to be treating him as her master, her owner, her god!

Blinker hurried over to Calanthra and knelt beside her. "Calanthra? Calanthra! Are you okay?! G-get up, this isn't like you-"

"DO NOT TAKE ME FROM HIM!" Calanthra shrieked, her dignity as the First Fairy Queen vanishing in an instant. "I worship my liege, I worship the great one! All hail Lord Timothy! I had eyes but could not see! I will repent for the rest of my life, milord! Forgive me for my insolence!!"

Calanthra tried to raise her head, but her eyes started to sting, blinded with tears of adulation. She was too awed by Timothy's presence to look at him directly anymore. It was as if Timothy had become an Archangel bathed in golden light. Looking at him was akin to looking directly at a star taken human form. Power radiated from his body. He simply stood there, unmoving, uncaring about the harshness of the universe. He was her light! He was the savior of the fairies! No matter what he commanded, she would obey him until the end of time!

Timothy frowned. He couldn't read Calanthra's thoughts, but it was clear even half the strength of Yredelemnul's Disdain had completely overwhelmed her. He thought at most it might scare her a little, frighten her, turn her against him... but this? *This??*

He had no idea what to do.

"I... seem to have... made Calanthra, um, worship... me." Timothy said haltingly, awkwardly. "I didn't expect this to happen."

"Oh, lord Timothy, of course you could not have foreseen how your greatness would affect me!" Calanthra cried, her tears falling to the grass as she bowed her head, refusing to lift it. "How could one as powerful and mighty as you comprehend the smallness of my thoughts?! I am but a weak woman, a pitiful worm in your eyes! Lord Timothy, allow me to follow you for the rest of eternity! Allow me to become yours in mind, body, and soul, so that I might-"

Before Calanthra could say any other embarrassing words, Blinker quickly summoned a force field around her, causing both fairies to become invisible and vanish from the eyes of the spectators.

All became quiet again.

Timothy's eye twitched. He could hear some of the crocodiles muttering under their breaths, but crocodiles were so obnoxiously loud that even their 'whispers' were fully audible to someone with decent enough hearing.

"...see that? Graugh... he just looked at her... and she became his slave."

"Scary. Maybe he really did dominate that Dark One lady."

"What if he used that power on us?"

"I... I don't wanna think about it. S-scary... kyargh..."

"-thought I could take him in a fight. But now? Nuh-uh, I ain't stupid..."

The crocodiles slowly started to pull away. Before long, they turned tail and quickly left the area one by one, leaving Timothy alone with only a handful of people he knew well. Among them were his fellow dungeon-delvers, his mom, Rebecca, and Kar.

"What did you do to Calanthra?" Fiona asked her son, as she gently rested a palm on his shoulder. "It seemed like you just... *looked at her*, and then..."

"Yredelemnul's Disdain." Timothy said. "It has a possible effect of dominating the mind of other life forms and turning them into my servants, but I thought it would only work on people much weaker than me. I was mainly worried the power would scare Calanthra silly, not... this."

Rebecca wandered over to Timothy, a thoughtful look on her face.

"Calanthra was wrong." Rebecca said, analyzing the situation with logic as she always did. "She thought that because of her proximity to Yredelemnul's Eye, she had become resistant to its effects. But in actuality, she was greatly weakened by its aura. She hates and fears it more than any other being in the galaxy. Struck with the power of Yredelemnul's Disdain, all her emotions must have burst out, causing this situation."

Timothy sighed softly. He looked at the other fairy queens, who had taken several steps back and were once again looking at him with deep hostility.

"I'm sorry. Truly." Timothy said. "If I had known this would happen, I would have refused Calanthra more firmly. I don't really have a way to 'undo' it... maybe the effect will wear off over time?"

It was the first time Timothy had used his power and gotten such a result. He had no practical understanding of how its nuances worked. Now he was regretting that lack of knowledge.

"Let's hope that's the case." Fiona muttered.

With Calanthra's fate shrouded in mystery by Blinker's force-field, Timothy decided to change the subject.

"So... mom? How did Chrona change like this?" Timothy asked. "I only spent a week in the Dungeon, yet somehow it was ten months on Chrona? And even ten months doesn't seem like enough time for all... *this*."

"The Dungeon had a lower time dilation ratio than Chrona, but not at the level of realspace." Fiona said. "I don't know if it applies to all Dungeons, Po's Library, or just this one time. You'll definitely want to factor it in, in the future. I also need to take better precautions. You nearly brought a Dark One here. I let you open the portal right in the middle of an open field, but next time, I'll have you open it inside a Kill Room I've built to contain possible Dungeon Breaks."

Fiona continued to explain. "While you were gone, I made a lot of progress. Ten months for me allowed me to master my abilities to no small degree, which also sped up my development work on Chrona, as well as countless personal projects. Have you looked at my character sheet?"

Timothy shook his head. He'd been way too busy to do that what with the tribunal and everything else. He also wasn't in the greatest mental state following the death of Sylphid and betrayal of Marigold, but that was another problem entirely.

With a thought, Timothy activated Yredelemnul's Eye and brought up his mother's character page. He could finally see all the details except for descriptions of Skills and such.

* * *

Techmancer - Leader of Chrona - Phantasmal Mortal

A lifeform created artificially by the Wordsmith. Formerly unable to survive without a special magical apparatus linked to Chrona's dimensional space, this entity can now survive outside Chrona in a limited capacity, and her phantasmal existence is becoming stronger all the time.

The Techmancer is a master of technology whose abilities grow more formidable over time. She is the leader of Chrona, and is using her new powers to rapidly uplift Chrona's people so that they might find a way to survive a coming apocalypse. She is the only member of her sub-species, and she is driven to amount to something beyond what her original creator designed her to do.

Fiona Hiro - Phantasmal Human/Chrona

Level 32 | Techmancer | Mortal

HP 70/70

AP 55/55 | MP 92/92

STR 8 | DEX 13

INT 17 | WIS 18

DEF 8 | RES 9

CHA 13 | LUK 13

CON 7 | END 19

Resistances: Physical 95%. Telepathy 100%. Electric 75%. Plasma 22%.

Weaknesses: Magic 75%.

Active Skills: Mother's Intuition, Construct Item (Lv 10), Deconstruct Item (Lv 10), Empower Item (Lvl 10), Create Blueprints (Lv 7), Transmute Material (Lv 5), Telekinesis (Lv 2), Flight (Lv 3), Dimensional Manipulation, Replicate Brain, Replicate Life-Form, Tech Interfacing, Tech Jump, Hacking (Lv 2), 14 more...

Passive Skills: Player's Body, Player's Mind (Toggle), Phantasmal Entity, Wall-Phasing, Consume Nutrients, Phase Shift, Adaptive Modulation, 6 more...

Talent Slots: 0/1

Prestige: N/A

* * *

Timothy was floored. He had quickly grown to Level 25 in the dungeon, but his mom had flown way past him! It seemed that, as long as one was persistent, ten months of Chrona-time could easily be worth a week in the Dungeon, if not more. It was obvious to him that not only did his mother have way more skills than him, but they were much higher quality, and even though he could only see their names and not their descriptions, he could easily tell she had been very deliberate in what skills she leveled up and for what reasons.

Unlike him, who had been rather haphazard, picking skills somewhat at random.

"You were gone a long time." Fiona said, smiling at her son. Her eyes had a hint of sadness to them. "I missed you so much that it hurt to even think of what you might be going through in that Dungeon. But I knew you were under the effect of time dilation, so I wasn't *too* worried."

"How did you know that?" Timothy asked.

"Po told me." Fiona replied.

"You can talk to Po?!" Timothy blurted out, astonished.

Fiona chuckled. "Of course. It wasn't easy. I had to build a translation device, since I didn't luck out and get the skill you did. But after a few months of work, I managed to put one together that could translate Po's words to me and vice-versa. He and I talked a bunch of times. I was the only person who could enter the portal you guys left behind, and

the only one who could actually see it, so it had to be me. I made sure to pop in a few times a month and check the status of your journey."

Fiona gave Timothy a lot of clues about what she'd gone through while he was gone. She hadn't said much, but what she had said was quite a game-changer. She opened his eyes to major problems he simply hadn't thought about.

If the Dungeon broke, wouldn't Chrona have been in big trouble? Fiona made it clear she had designed a new Kill Room for the next time Timothy and the others went inside, assuming they ever would. Timothy wasn't so certain himself.

Without Marigold to act as the tank, Timothy was hesitant to go back in. They only survived by the skin of their teeth this time, and he wasn't eager to repeat that experience.

"By the way." Fiona said, after a few moments of looking at Timothy with an odd gaze. "Why *did* you enter that dreadful Dungeon? Didn't you see how difficult it was?"

"Difficult?" Timothy asked. "Po told us it was rated as 'very easy.'"

He paused. "I do have to admit though, it was an insanely difficult Dungeon... his rating felt like a slap across the face."

"You really didn't look around the Library? Ask him a few more questions first?" Fiona asked, looking at her son with sardonic amusement. "Timothy... Po pulled that story from the Cosmic shelves. It was rated as very easy... *for Cosmics*. The rating for Mortals would have been beyond 'Extreme.' Did you seriously just take him at his word?"

Timothy's stomach fell into his shoes. "What?! That bastard. He lied to us."

Ferral and Raavul didn't change their expressions, but Timothy could feel their gazes on his back.

[Timothy, we were relying on you to be the interpreter. You ought to have asked more questions.] Raavul said, her tone disapproving. [On the other hand, the fact we survived such a terrifying Dungeon should mean that future Dungeons will be a lot easier... provided you make *sure* we pick those easier dungeons.]

If Timothy could feel all his emotions, he might have curled up into a ball of embarrassment and died right there on the spot. "Well. That's. Um. Right, I'll do that next time then."

He remained stone-faced for now, but who knew what emotions he would feel in 24 hours, when he had the ability to deactivate the Mind of Logic and die of cringe.

Timothy looked in Calanthra and Blinker's direction. They hadn't reappeared yet.

"Let's go somewhere private and talk for a while, mom." Timothy said, suddenly feeling tired and drained from all the stress he'd been under. "I could use a breather."

Fiona nodded. She gestured for Rebecca and Paimon to follow, and the four of them headed deeper into the city, while the rest left to attend to their own matters.

For now, Timothy couldn't do anything about Calanthra. He might as well leave her with Blinker to try and calm down.

As for Timothy, he had much to discuss with his mother...

Part 759: Champion of Creation

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy, Fiona, Rebecca, and Paimon all made their way deeper into Chrona, leaving behind Blinker and the others to deal with Calanthra. Timothy felt guilty about what he'd accidentally done to her, but there was nothing more he could do to resolve the situation now.

It took him less than a minute to put Calanthra out of sight and out of mind, because once he saw what his mother had been up to, his imagination was immediately captivated.

Ferral had opened a Dungeon portal outside the east side of Chrona, which was an under-developed area with lots of grass and flowers. Thus, Timothy's companions had only managed to spot the tall buildings on that side of the main city, and those structures had obscured the dramatic changes inside the city itself.

It didn't take long before Timothy and Paimon were completely lost. They didn't recognize anything. The Spynet Sphere wasn't in the center of the city anymore, and neither was Timothy's old house. The crocodile population appeared to have doubled in the last ten months, which was quite ridiculous considering they'd been increasing slowly and steadily over the last 200 years. Everywhere Timothy looked, crocodiles were roaming here and there. He spotted hundreds of hatchlings roaming the streets, cute little waddling babies that still crawled around on four limbs much quicker than a human child would.

The city felt alive in a way it didn't before. It was as if Timothy were looking at a living organism, and the conveyor belts around the city were Chrona's veins. Conveyor belts were scattered across the skies, with large boxes and crates of items zipping around, left and right. Timothy didn't know what their purpose was, but they weren't scattered haphazardly. They actually seemed somewhat artistic in how they had been placed with great care so as to not look hideous and ugly. They were also surprisingly silent, not constantly drumming up unpleasant noise throughout the air like one might expect.

"I made a lot of changes while you were gone." Fiona explained. "Probably 70% of those changes happened in the last couple of months. The more my abilities have

improved, the faster I've been able to solve the problems I faced."

Paimon gestured to the conveyor belts in the sky. "What is the purpose of those?"

"I originally started putting conveyors on the ground, but I quickly found that they got in people's way, especially when I increased the number and speed of shipments transferring between my warehouses." Fiona explained. "I moved them into the sky a few months ago so we'd have more walking space throughout the city. See, I unlocked the Automated Factory and Crafting systems before you guys even left, but it took me a while to figure out how synergistic the two of them were. Ever since I did, I've been able to turn Chrona into a large scale automated factory that accomplishes a lot of strategic objectives all at once."

"Over there to the north, that's one of the three main Sorting Warehouses." Fiona explained. You can't see it, but I built a bunch of sorting arms to process package deliveries and other such things quickly and efficiently. With Rebecca's help, and some of my new abilities, we recently added digitized pseudo-Cybernites to the warehouse to sort packages. They aren't sentient, but they're intelligent enough to get the work done quickly and efficiently."

"We haven't solved the Energy Crisis fully," Rebecca chimed in, "but we've reduced the energy deficit a lot. We also haven't solved the problem of Chrona's time dilation speeding up, but I think we might be able to do so in due time."

Timothy gave Rebecca and his mother a long glance. "Mom, when my Eye of Yredelemnul leveled up, I gained the ability to look at your stats in greater detail. Why is your class called 'Techmancer'?"

"I promoted at level 25." Fiona said. "When you reach level 25, I'll explain everything to you."

"I'm level 25 now." Timothy replied, causing his mother to jump slightly, then turn and look at him with surprise.

"You are?!" Fiona exclaimed. "But... how? Weren't you only inside that Dungeon for a week? It took me eight months to climb to level 25!"

"I, ah... I leveled up quickly thanks to some good luck." Timothy said, dodging the question on how he'd amassed so much experience so quickly. He still felt deeply guilty about murdering potentially hundreds of lifeforms inside the Dark Forest. "I have a lot of

gains I haven't had time to process yet. I leveled up a bunch of times, but we were in such a rush to get out of the Forest, I never really looked at everything I picked up. I have a ton of lootboxes, new items, new skill choices to make... it's been quite hectic. And until I choose a Promotion, I won't be able to level up anymore."

"Regarding that last part, you don't have to worry." Fiona said. "The King Network will track all the experience you earn, so even if you earn enough to level up, it won't be wasted. Once you choose your promotion, you'll gain a bunch of levels quickly."

"Still, I want to do my promotion soon..." Timothy said. "How does it work, mom?"

Fiona gestured toward one particular skyscraper with a conspicuous dome planted on its top.

"Let's go inside first, and then I'll explain everything you need to know." She said.

* * *

Twenty minutes later, Timothy and the rest had arrived inside his new home. The Spynet Sphere had been moved to the top of the central skyscraper inside Chrona, a building which was thirty stories tall. While it was the tallest building in Chrona by a couple of stories, as far as skyscrapers on ancient Earth went, it actually wasn't even close to as tall as the heights those buildings reached. Still, Chrona was a tiny fraction of the size of Earth, so the new Spynet Tower was proportionally far bigger relative to its planet.

Fiona and the rest exited an elevator at the penthouse suite on the 30th floor, with the Spynet Sphere being positioned directly above them.

"Unfortunately," Fiona said, "the Spynet itself doesn't work anymore. Due to dilation acceleration, all the monitors have stopped showing anything happening across the Milky Way. Until I solve the issue, it'll have to remain a decoration atop this building. It doesn't really matter though, seeing as without Jason, Chrona can't materially affect realspace. We need to focus on our internal crisis before the dimension implodes on itself from temporal and spatial stress."

Timothy felt his stomach tighten at his mother's words. Her emotions were calm, but he could sense that a terrible weight was growing on her shoulders. If things continued to progress as they had been, Chrona would spin faster and faster out of control until it collapsed, killing everyone inside.

Naturally, the young man did not want to see that happen.

Everyone sat down in the penthouse living room, except for Paimon, who sauntered off to cook some food. He didn't have much to add to the discussion, and he enjoyed cooking, so it was a good way for him to pass the time. That left Timothy alone with his mother and Rebecca.

"So, tell me about promotions." Timothy said. "Not to be melodramatic, but I'm dying to know."

"When you choose to promote, you will be offered three options." Fiona said, her expression solemn. "I was offered four as a result of my passive skill. I always get an additional choice, whereas you do not."

She continued. "The four choices I was offered all related to who I 'am' as a person. I needed several days to choose who I wanted to become. They were deeply personal, and not at all simple to decide between. I might have been paralyzed forever, if I didn't finagle an important detail out of Umi first."

Timothy raised his eyebrow. "An important detail?"

"In due time." Fiona said, refusing to answer until it became pertinent. "Here's a paper I wrote some time back, showing the choices I was offered. I wrote it to give to you when you were ready to promote, but it seems that day arrived far sooner than I could have imagined..."

* * *

You have reached Level 25. Congratulations. You are now eligible to promote to a higher state of existence.

Class Promotion: TRUEBORN HERO.

Once upon a time, you were a human known as Phoebe Hiro. You were a singular entity, one and the same. That was until the Wordsmith split your essence from hers and turned you into a unique life form capable of growing beyond your original intent. But what if you could go back in time and reform yourself as a fully corporeal human? What if Phoebe Hiro had become Phoebe the Hero?

As a Trueborn, you will cease to be an ethereal entity. You will become a fully flesh and blood human, with all the upsides and downsides of such a transition. You will gain incredible Heroic power, making you a powerhouse in your own right. The abilities you obtain will closely align with your interests and personality. How exactly those will

manifest depend on the choices you make inside the King Network, but you will become a living weapon all your enemies fear and your allies adore. This power may even unlock the secret to saving Chrona from its inevitable collapse.

Class Promotion: TECHMANCER.

Long ago, you were an individual known as Phoebe Hiro, but your conscious mind has been Fiona Hiro for longer than even Phoebe Hiro existed as Phoebe Hiro. Why do you cling to your old identity when the man you loved has passed into memory along with your former self? Embrace who you are now. Empower yourself to become an incorporeal lifeform possessing incredible power. Abandon the concept of a fleshly body and obtain power overwhelming.

As a Techmancer, you will cast aside flesh and bone to interface with the Imaginary Realm, becoming something not quite human. You will be capable of phasing through solid objects at will, passing between dimensions, and no longer remaining tethered to the realm of Chrona. You will attune yourself technology in grand ways. You will become capable of interfacing with technology at a whim. You will be able to construct grand technological marvels with relative ease. You will be able to research novel inventions that make even the Volgrim gasp in awe. With this power, you may even be able to solve the time dilation crisis looming over your domain.

Class Promotion: DIVINE ARTISAN.

Aside from Phoebe Hiro, there was one other person you admired more than anyone else. That person was Jason Hiro. As the Wordsmith, he was capable of reshaping reality with a single word. You don't have the same interests in him, but what if you were a little closer to him in terms of potential? What could you accomplish?

As a Divine Artisan, you will become highly attuned to the spiritual and magical side of reality. You will remain a phantasmal life form, but you will become more spiritually impressive, allowing you to craft divine artifacts on par with legendary weapons like Excalibur and Solomon's Crown. You will gain the ability to create weapons of war and tools capable of progressing your own abilities, and the abilities of others with great ease. Perhaps by using this power, you can solve the time dilation crisis approaching Chrona?

Class Promotion: CYBERNITE.

Corporeality. Flesh and bone. Incorporeality. Spiritual consciousness. Why choose either of these when a superior option is available? Abandon the concept of a 'soul' entirely. Become a Cybernite, like your close friend Rebecca. Obtain a modular body with power and customizability. Change who you 'are' at a whim. Manufacture different body variants and jump between them at will. One body for science, one body for construction, one body for war. All these bodies are still 'you', but better, superior, perfected over time.

As a Cybernite, your mind will become tremendously efficient, your thinking speed will accelerate a hundredfold, and you will gain all sorts of novel abilities to enhance who 'you' are on a fundamental level. Not a spirit, not a ghost, not a human, you will become a machine with her own thoughts and desires capable of infinite improvement. Perhaps by becoming a superior life form, you will be able to save everyone you love from the terrible fate of a dimensional collapse.

* * *

Timothy read over his mother's four promotion options. He felt a mixture of emotions.

Two throughlines were clear. Fiona thought a lot about Phoebe, and it was clear she always felt envious of her corporeal self. She also feared the impending doom facing Chrona, and hungered to solve the problem and save the lives of her friends and family.

Each of the four classes offered were deeply appealing in their own way. Timothy thought the Cybernite option was a bit odd, but maybe his mother actually did have an interest in becoming one? Timothy and Fiona were very different people, so just because he thought becoming a Cybernite sounded offputting, that didn't mean his mother did.

"Why didn't you choose the Trueborn Hero option?" Timothy asked. "It seems like the best one to me."

He looked at his mom. Even though she had chosen the Techmancer promotion, she seemed just as corporeal as when he left. Had she truly become a spiritual lifeform?

Fiona lowered her eyes. It seemed she had already guessed her son's thoughts.

"This... is not my real body." Fiona said hesitantly. "I wasn't sure how to break the news to you, Timothy. I'm not actually- this isn't really... me. This body you're looking at."

"It's not??" Timothy asked, bewildered. "Wait wait, mom, you're not... then what am I looking at?"

Rebecca grimaced. "Your mother has become a fully spiritual lifeform. The body before you is one of her avatars. It's a robotic body, similar to a Cybernite. Not quite as advanced, more human in design. She made it just so she could maintain a 'physical presence' among Chrona's people."

A long silence followed. Timothy felt a pit opening in his stomach. He reached over and touched his mother's face, and only now did he realize she wasn't instinctively reacting to his touch the way she usually would. Fiona smiled at him, but there was a 'delay' as if she was acting the way she thought she should.

It was as if his mother was watching from afar, piloting the body before him like a drone.

"Mom... where are you?" Timothy asked. He looked around the room and squinted, then activated Yredelemnul's Eye.

At that moment, Timothy noticed trails of spiritual energy in the air. Some of those trails were close to his left side, opposite where his mother's 'body' was seated. Timothy turned to his left and frowned.

"Mom?"

The spiritual energy in the air vibrated slightly.

"Yes. It's me." Fiona said, her voice now coming from that cluster of energy. "I'm sorry I didn't tell you sooner. It all happened so fast, you returning, Marigold's accusations, all of that."

Timothy looked at his 'mother' stonily. He felt like he wanted to cry, but he couldn't. The Mind of Logic prevented such a strong emotion from manifesting. Instead, he had to look at her stoically, as if he wasn't about to break in half from the trauma.

"Why?" Timothy asked quietly. "Why would you choose this path over becoming a Trueborn?"

"Because." Fiona said, her tone steady. "I spent several days weighing the pros and cons. Ultimately, I realized the ability to travel in and out of Chrona would be extremely beneficial to saving Chrona. I am currently an immortal lifeform. But, if I chose to become a Trueborn, I would become a powerful human, but a human nonetheless. I would have a ticking biological clock."

"Dad made you immortal." Timothy argued. "You told me he did."

"There's no way to know if the King Network would maintain that immortality once I transitioned into a flesh and blood body." Fiona replied. "And besides. I told you there was an important detail I managed to coax out of Umi, remember? It ultimately gave me the courage to make this choice."

She paused.

"Timothy, I found out that the King Network has a limit. When you reach Level 100, you will stop growing any further."

"What?" Timothy asked. "There's such a thing?"

"That wasn't the detail that made me change my mind." Fiona explained. "Actually, that was just an interesting tidbit I learned by accident. When I was choosing my promotion, Umi inadvertently let it slip that a Player can choose *multiple* promotions. They can only choose a new promotion once they reach Level 100. At that point, the new Promotion will reset to Level 25, and they will start gaining experience once again."

Timothy took a few seconds to digest this information.

"So... so this isn't permanent?" Timothy asked. "You chose the Techmancer option in order to gain the power to save Chrona, and then once you reached Level 100, you would be able to choose the Trueborn option as well?"

"That's right. But there's a caveat." Rebecca jumped in. "If your mother and I have understood the situation properly, a Player with multiple promotions would be able to switch between them. The skills and abilities of one promotion would only function when they are actively in that 'state' of existence. So, if your mother has unique abilities as a Techmancer, then she won't have access to those abilities as a Trueborn, not unless she switches to that promotion tree... and vice-versa."

Timothy's eyes brightened. With this new information, the fog in his heart lifted, and his anguish was alleviated somewhat.

"That- that's great, mom." Timothy said, breathing a sigh of relief. "But how long will it take you to reach Level 100? The amount of experience required increases over time."

"I don't know." Fiona answered honestly. "I reached Level 32 somewhat quickly... but that was mainly due to being able to complete a bunch of Quests from before my promotion using my Promotion's unique abilities. Once those quests were completed, the

new ones... have proven to be a lot harder. I think my growth is going to slow down quite a lot."

This additional information only made Timothy feel worse.

"How long before I can hug my real mom again?" Timothy asked quietly.

"I... I don't know, Timothy. I'm sorry." Fiona answered, her voice as low as his. "I can't revert back to a corporeal lifeform until I promote again... unless I obtain a skill that says otherwise."

"Oh."

That was all Timothy managed to say. His Mind of Logic was being pushed to the limit. Even if 95% of his emotions were removed, he'd gone through so much that the remaining 5% was still putting him in extreme distress.

"Let's... let's talk about your promotions. Okay, honey?" Fiona said gently. Her spiritual energy 'sat' beside him, but she was completely formless, like smoke on the wind. Timothy couldn't see her if he didn't keep Yredelemnul's Eye activated constantly, and Rebecca couldn't see her either.

Timothy stared forward at nothing in particular.

A few moment passed. He sighed.

"Okay."

Timothy activated his Character page. The Promotion option was lit up, and after a moment of hesitation, he tapped it, causing four brilliant options to appear before him.

* * *

You have reached Level 25. Congratulations. You are now eligible to promote to a higher state of existence.

Class Promotion: SUPERHUMAN.

You are your father's son. Already a Trueborn, you have manifested the power of video games and begun to empower others, including your own mother. But are you satisfied with your own level of strength? You are not a deep thinker like your adoptive or biological mother. You do not have the interest or inclination to fix Chrona's degrading time dilation. But what if that wasn't your purpose anyway? Humanity lacks powerhouses and champions. Become formidable. Become humanity's protector.

As a Superhuman, you will gain might and battle power beyond compare. Demon Emperors will fear your name. You will attract attention and notoriety as you grow in strength. Your ability to empower others will dramatically lessen, but you will become a force that makes the galaxy tremble. With this, others will respect you and bow to your interests. Even the mightiest Volgrim will become wary of offending you.

Class Promotion: YREDELEMNUL'S HEIR.

Already, you have begun to tap into the strength of a Ruler that is not your own. But what do you really know about Yredelemnul? Do you know who he was? Can you even comprehend what he accomplished? Your limited knowledge of Yredelemnul has shown you that the fairies may perhaps fear his power unfairly. Who says you have to become an evil psychopath just to wield the power of a dead Ruler? Harness his might and make it your own.

As Yredelemnul's Heir, you will amass all the powers he once did, eventually surpassing him and becoming an entity the Dark Ones cower before in fear. You will become personally powerful, but also capable of building armies by influencing the minds of others. The Milky Way has more threats it must face someday beyond the Kolvaxians. Why not gain the strength to protect your home? Even if it costs you some of your humanity... isn't that a small price worth paying?

Class Promotion: LORD OF CREATION.

Perhaps you are more similar to your mothers than you thought. You've never shown too much interest in creating technology or spiritual constructs, but who says that always has to be the case? With your mother teaching you from the side, you can become versatile, solving problems even she cannot. Wouldn't it be nice to help your mother for once, rather than leeching off her hard work?

As the Lord of Creation, you will gain the ability to create weapons, tools, even life forms. Your ability to create objects and creatures will surpass even your father and mother, but you will not be very competent in battle. You will serve an auxiliary role, building up others so that they may take down the threats humanity faces. Perhaps this is for the best. Perhaps becoming a creator will serve the people around you better than becoming a mere muscle-brained lunkhead.

Class Promotion: HAREM KING.

You love women, but do women love you? It doesn't matter what the others think, you should be true to yourself. Why limit yourself to just one mate or spouse when you can have them all? You are who you are. Do not deny your carnal urges. Using your powers, sweep away all the beauties of the world and gain power through them as well. Even alien empires stronger than yours will inevitably have powerful women you could seduce. Make their power yours.

As the Harem King, you would gain unparalleled ability to seduce females of all other species, and even males, if your desires ever inclined that way. Whatever powers they possessed would become yours to wield at will. Not merely a tool for selfish pleasure, you could pass on potent abilities to your harem, growing their strength and making their power, along with yours, even more potent as time went on. Could love truly become capable of conquering hatred?

* * *

Timothy was silent for a long while. He stared at the promotion screen while his mother and Rebecca waited patiently.

Eventually, Timothy took out a pen and paper. He wrote down every word, even if the final entry was extremely embarrassing. Were he not in the Mind of Logic, he might have hidden it from his mother, but that was not the case, so he didn't. She had already shown him an embarrassing side of herself, revealing her true thoughts and desires. Why should he not do the same?

When he finished writing, Rebecca and Fiona took some time to read what he'd penned. They read the words out loud and looked at once another every so often. They gave Timothy several queer looks regarding the Harem King description, but Fiona was much more worried about the Yredelemnul's Heir option. It went to show how deeply the Ruler had pressed his claws into Timothy's psyche.

"Why are there four options?" Rebecca eventually asked Fiona. "I thought you only had the fourth option because of your passive skill."

"Well, come to think of it, my skill only mentioned lootboxes. Maybe I was wrong." Fiona replied. "More importantly... it seems Timothy has a serious decision to make. We can easily cross off the two weird options, leaving only the Superhuman and Lord of Creation promotions. Basically, he has the choice between personal empowerment, or empowerment of others. There's no real middle ground here."

Timothy thought for a while.

"Why not the Yredelemnul's Heir choice?" Timothy asked. "It served me well in the dungeon."

"Absolutely not!" Fiona exclaimed, a trace of panic in her voice. "Timothy Edward Hiro, don't you even THINK of picking that horrible, horrible option! And the weird *rapey-option*, that's definitely off the table too, got it?!"

"I wasn't even thinking of the Harem King one." Timothy said, which was true, given that in his emotionless state, lust was not an emotion he was capable of feeling. Perhaps if he were in his normal mind-state, that might not be the case. "But I think ignoring Yredelemnul's Eye is a bad idea. True, it once belonged to an evil Ruler who wiped out a galaxy. But so what? I've already established his power doesn't come from hatred and megalomania. It comes from intense mental focus. In my Mind of Void, I can draw out extreme power from his Eye already. It could be a potent force equalizer."

Timothy continued. "Besides. You said there's no in-between option, but that's wrong. The Superhuman promotion makes me individually powerful. The Lord of Creation promotion allows me to empower others. Yredelemnul's Heir allows me to do *both*."

"Much as I hate to say it, Timothy is correct." Paimon said, as he returned from the kitchen holding a plate with soup and sandwiches for his master. "Furthermore, I think the Harem King option is not as bad as you're making it out to be. Timothy is, after all, a hot blooded young male human. It's only natural he desires copulation with a harem of beautiful females."

Timothy might have broken out into a violent coughing fit if he weren't in the Mind of Logic, but as it was, he simply stared stonily at Paimon's side profile. "You were listening to our discussion?"

"Oh yes, my hearing is excellent." Paimon said, reminding everyone he was still a demon with extremely sharp senses. "I caught the major points of what your promotion entailed."

"I'm leaning toward Lord of Creation." Rebecca said. "We need all the artifact and technology creators we can get."

"I disagree." Fiona said. "I'm already capable of creating powerful weapons and tools. Timothy should fulfill a different niche. I think Superhuman is best. Humanity needs a

champion to protect our interests. Relying on the Phoenix, Beelzebub, or even Melody is a ticking time bomb."

"I think Yredelemnul's Eye is quite appealing." Paimon said. "I saw how much damage it did in the Dark Forest. He's already converted Calanthra from an enemy into an ally. The Eye's utility is demonstrably robust. I wouldn't discount it."

Fiona gave Paimon an ugly glare, but she didn't say anything. His logic was sound, even if it seemed painfully obvious Yredelemnul's Eye would turn Timothy evil. She didn't believe her son was stupid enough to choose it.

"I think my mother has the right idea." Timothy eventually said. "I'm going to disregard Yredelemnul's Eye. I'm also going to set aside the Harem King option. The decision for me is going to be between Superhuman and Lord of Creation. I simply need to assess all the possibilities to determine which one makes the most sense."

And thus, the choice was laid out.

Would Timothy pick personal power, or would he choose to become a powerful creator, like his mothers and father before him?

It was a decision that would reshape the future of the galaxy.

Part 760: Old Gold's Hold

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Chrona.

Timothy had a huge decision before him. It could easily be argued it was the biggest decision of his life, at least up to this point.

Timothy wasn't only picking his first promotion, but choosing a path that would not be alterable for the next several years. Unless he went on a genocide like in the Dark Forest and killed a massive number of living creatures to quickly reach level 100, he would be stuck on this promotion track, unable to pick another for a distressingly long time.

But, at the same time, his decision wasn't *final*. Timothy had not been made immortal by his father, but it seemed possible, perhaps even likely, that the King Network would give him access to immortality at some point. If it didn't, perhaps his mom or Rebecca could bio-engineer something.

As such, once he reached Level 100 in this promotion, he could swap to another one, gaining a huge amount of versatility in a few years. He was not permanently 'locked in' as every other Trueborn, including his father, had been. In this way, Timothy had earned a privilege beyond compare.

Now, the only question was what option he would pick.

"Yredelemnul's Heir really does seem to do it all." Timothy said out loud. "In terms of personal power, it allowed me to go toe-to-toe with a Peak Mortal existence, and I won. There were extenuating circumstances weakening my opponent, but most of those circumstances were *me*. I weakened him to make him easier for me to take out. I can only imagine that a bit more progress with Yredelemnul would make me unstoppable below the Cosmic Realm."

He paused for a moment to consider his words. Then he continued.

"The Harem King promotion is more than it seems on the surface. Notice how it says I'll be able to add the power of my harem to myself and swap their powers around at will. Doesn't that sound familiar?"

Rebecca opened her mouth slightly, a rare sign of mild surprise.

"...It *does* sound familiar. It's quite similar to Emperor Auger's powers. Or rather, Demon Deity Auger. He can swap around his subordinates' abilities and his own at will to himself and his minions."

"Auger controls his subordinates completely." Fiona said, scowling. "He speaks politely, but in truth, he's a villain to the core. He can revoke the power his goons possess and leave them completely defenseless, forcing them to obey his every command. Timothy's Harem option sounds even worse, because he would be taking advantage of women! That's mind-rape, pure and simple, even if you don't do anything to them or their bodies. Enslaving other minds is wrong. It's evil and depraved."

Fiona genuinely might not have felt this way at some point in her life, but she had spent over a hundred years around Jason, and he had influenced her views greatly. Even though Phoebe had once been quite repulsed by the horrors in King Arthur's dungeon, even she might not have opposed enslaving demons, given the right circumstances. But that was then, that was Phoebe, and Fiona was *not* Phoebe any longer.

In her eyes, after listening to Jason's lectures countless times, she found that even the thought of slavery made her stomach turn. The thought her son had accidentally mind-raped Calanthra was terrible, but she could at least excuse it as an accident born of Calanthra's hubris.

It would be completely different if her son chose to use such an ability over and over again in the future. Fiona would feel deep regret if he walked such a path.

"Auger isn't the only one like that." Timothy said. "Jepthath is similar, yes? And he's one of the 'good guys'. He's on *our* side. Mom, how do you reconcile the fact that Jepthath has just as much control over his Legion as Auger has over his subordinates, yet we call Jepthath an ally?"

"That's... that's not the same thing." Fiona said, feeling uneasy due to her son's cold, emotionless questioning. He didn't even bat an eye when saying such words. "Jepthath allowed people to join him after making clear what the results would be. Auger pressured people into joining him. Jepthath's power is also not actually controlled by Jepthath himself. People have full access to it and control it as much as their bodies will allow."

"That answer is nonsense." Paimon said.

Paimon sat across from Timothy. He couldn't see or sense Fiona's spiritual form, but he knew the 'Fiona' sitting on Timothy's right was a cyborg avatar, not her real self, so he

simply addressed the air in the room when he spoke.

"The differences between Jepthath and Auger are minute and nitpicky at best. They both grant immense powers to their subordinates, and they both can revoke those powers under certain circumstances. As for Auger, I have it on good authority that the vast majority of his followers sought him out for their own personal empowerment. He didn't even advertise his abilities, demons simply came to him looking for a handout! Even I once considered joining him."

"Then why *didn't* you join him?" Fiona asked, annoyed by Paimon's interjections. He seemed to be pushing her son toward a path she definitely didn't want Timothy to take.

"I had my own pride." Paimon answered, his tone mild.

Timothy dipped one of the sandwiches Paimon had brought him into the beef soup. He took a bite, savoring its rich and meaty taste.

After eating a few bites and thinking for a while, Timothy shook his head.

"I currently have no carnal interest in the Harem King route, mom, but I think you're dismissing it way too quickly. Even thinking logically, it seems an extremely powerful promotion worth considering. It fits well into my general nature when not under the influence of the Mind of Logic. I do believe I would enjoy using it... perhaps get a thrill out of doing so."

Timothy paused, then shrugged. "Even so, I don't think it is the ideal choice for me, right now. Let's think about the remaining two options."

Fiona's unease grew. Her son was speaking 'logically' but the fact he had such strong arguments for the two worst options did not bode well in her eyes.

"The ability to become a powerful creator is extremely appealing." Timothy said. "It seems that I would be capable of creating technology, artifacts, even lifeforms. What that entails exactly, I'm not sure. Could I create biological weapons? Could I create artificial humans? Superhumans? Could I re-sequence the genomes of existing humans, in the same way my father removed the Human Flaw? Could I improve on the human genome enough to make us competitive with the other life-forms?"

Timothy thought for a moment. "Pets. I could create pets. Cute pets, combat pets, creatures based on Earth lifeforms, monsters, even exobeasts. Not to mention brand new

creatures we've never seen before. Maybe I could design something capable of counteracting the Plague."

Timothy smiled, ever so slightly. "I could make catgirls too. That seems like something I'd enjoy."

Fiona's face fell. "There you go, thinking about girls again!"

"So what if I do?" Timothy countered, looking his mother right in her metaphorical spirit-eyes. "I understand that I acted poorly in the recent past. I was lonely, depressed, and felt like a failure. I had no confidence, and spied on women in a manner I'm sure you and several others found disgusting. But fundamentally, so what if I have a strong libido or desire to fraternize with attractive women? Is there something wrong with that? Or was there only something wrong with the manner in which I expressed myself?"

Fiona was taken aback. "Well, no, of course there's nothing wrong with... a young man... being interested in women. I- I wouldn't mean to imply otherwise. But we're talking about using your powers to control women. That's wrong, Timothy."

"Mmm. I agree." Timothy said, stroking his chin. "I was only joking about making catgirls too. Or maybe that was my emotional side acting out in a small way. Either way, you have been pushing me away from choosing Yredelemnul and the Harem King options because you don't like the fact they could be used for ill intent. But what if I used the power of Creation to make an army of women subservient to my desires? Wouldn't that be just as evil?"

Fiona's expression softened. "I suppose... yes. Timothy... when did you become so formidable with your words?"

Timothy shrugged. "Even if I choose to become a Superhuman, I could still become strong enough to overpower any woman I want and force her to be 'mine'. That would be just as evil as the other options, showing that no matter which choice I make, I have the capacity to act evil if I so desire. Therefore, the question should not be 'which choices are the least evil' but 'will I use my powers ethically, no matter which choice I make'? I leave it to your imagination to determine whether I would do so or not."

Fiona fell silent. For once, she was completely stumped. True, two of the options leaned much more heavily on brainwashing and mind control, but forcing someone to do something with raw strength or using creation powers to make submissive catgirl slaves were also perfectly plausible things her son could do if he wanted to act like a vile fiend.

Thus, she had nothing she could say. Fiona simply nodded her head. "Alright. You win this argument, Timothy. I guess... we just have to consider which of the powers are most practical and best for you."

Seeing that even Fiona had been defeated by Timothy's logic, Rebecca was impressed. Timothy had grown a lot more than even she knew over the last couple of months.

"If all the options are on the table, then I'm going to vote for Yredelemnul's Heir." Rebecca immediately pivoted. "Like Timothy said, it offers a whole suite of options to meet his needs. Personal power, the ability to command an army, auxiliary abilities, and it has already proven its worth. The chance Yredelemnul might corrupt Timothy and somehow take over his body is noteworthy, but I have a feeling Timothy's Trueborn powers will make him capable of resisting."

Even though she had just agreed that all options were on the table, Fiona was still a little baffled by Rebecca's abrupt change of heart. "You really think that's the best option?"

"I do." Rebecca said.

"I agree." Paimon added. "I've seen what Yredelemnul's Eye was capable of. I would rather have Timothy obtain the power than someone else."

Timothy rubbed his chin. "I think I agree with both of you. The Lord of Creation promotion feels like a mimicry of you, mom. The Superhuman path seems strong but shallow, lacking in auxiliary abilities. It feels strong, but also like I would be extremely limited in how I handle situations. When all you have is a hammer, every problem starts to look like a nail. And while I do think the Harem King promotion is extremely strong, there's one last thing I haven't mentioned."

Timothy smiled. "The Eye of Yredelemnul doesn't grant me any creation abilities, but it's effectively a combination of Superhuman and Harem Lord. I can dominate the minds of other Sentients, both female *and* male, and I will additionally gain incredible combat power. It hits two of my available promotion paths. In that regard, I think it's perfect."

Fiona felt defeated. Despite her best efforts, her son was still leaning toward the option she feared the most. But ultimately, she had no rebuttal to what everyone else had said. Even Rebecca had come around to the Eye of Yredelemnul.

"If you couldn't pick the Eye, what would you choose? How would you rank the abilities?" Fiona asked.

Timothy didn't answer immediately. He pondered the choices for a while instead.

"I think I would put Yredelemnul's Eye in first place, the Lord of Creation in second, Harem King in third, and Superhuman in last. I like all the offered promotions, and if I didn't have a choice and the King Network simply picked one at random for me, I'd be happy with any of them. But ultimately, I think I value versatility over power. Having a grab bag of tricks really worked to my advantage in the Dark Forest. I'd like to maintain that for my future growth as well, expending it as much as possible."

As such, Timothy had made his decision. The System had put the Eye of Yredelemnul front and center since he acquired his powers, and that had certainly influenced his final decision. But in the end, it was a strong ability and it had a lot of appeal for him.

"Oh and one other thing." Timothy said. "With everything that's happened with Calanthra, I don't know if Aunt Blinker will be able to snap her out of the mental state I put her in, but I'm hoping choosing the Eye will give me ways of doing so myself."

Fiona's emotions brightened, even if only just a little. It turned out her son had been thinking further ahead than even she had, worrying about how to break Calanthra out of the mental state he'd put her in. She'd been letting her emotions get the best of her ever since her little boy returned, but now she realized he wasn't a child anymore. He was becoming a man, one with his own thoughts and opinions.

"I select the Yredelemnul's Heir option." Timothy said out loud as he tapped the button before him.

Unlike his mother, he hadn't needed weeks to decide. Her counsel, along with the opinions of Paimon and Rebecca, had helped him reach a decision quickly. Timothy believed that even if Ferral had been present, he'd have made the same decision.

Perhaps if Timothy had not been in the Mind of Logic, he might have made a different decision. Though, in truth, with his thoughts and emotions utterly in shambles following Sylphid's death and Marigold's betrayal, Timothy likely wouldn't have been able to decide on *anything* until he resolved all that trauma first.

A brilliant light lit up around Timothy. His eyes widened. He felt himself lifting off the chair and his body being drawn toward a brilliant golden portal that opened in the air

above him.

"Huh? What the- mom? Mom??"

Timothy looked down at his friends and mother, but they were still looking at 'him', his hand frozen in midair, his finger pressing upon the button that would promote him to a new existence. Timothy realized with a start that his soul had been separated from his body, and he hadn't seen it coming!

All of a sudden, Timothy flew up into the portal, and the world vanished behind him.

* * *

Timothy stumbled forward. He found himself shakily standing on a rock with a flat top, suspended inside a mystical land with swirling energies of light and dark. It was as if he had arrived at the edge of a black hole's event horizon.

Before him, several levitating stones curved from left to right, slowly rising before a giant temple in the sky, a temple with graven images of avian creatures, bird-people Timothy had never seen before. They stood tall, majestic, their eyes looking forward as if gazing toward an uncertain future. Their expressions were solemn and holy. They appeared to be priests of a religion Timothy couldn't identify.

"What... what the hell? Where am I?" Timothy asked.

His voice spread out, then seemed to dissipate. The energy swirling in the realm around him moved slowly, peacefully. It seemed to thrum when he spoke, but he wasn't sure whether he had hallucinated its movements or not.

A voice spoke from the distance. It sounded frail, shrill, and male, like the sounds of a squeaky-voiced old man.

"Administrator. Step forward, please."

Timothy hesitated. He didn't exactly feel fear, especially with his Mind of Logic active, but he was certainly feeling wary. His mother hadn't mentioned anything like this happening when she promoted, and there was no way she would forget to do so.

Slowly, Timothy took a step forward. He carefully pressed his shoe onto one of the levitating rocks, and it didn't budge a millimeter. He gently eased his full weight onto it, then took another step forward, toward the next floating rock.

There weren't any fences to keep him from falling. It seemed as if he would fall into the void below if he wasn't careful. Timothy's gut tightened each time he took a step. It took five long minutes, but eventually he made it to the end of the thirty-step path. He was sweating from exhaustion due to putting all his focus on not falling off the edge. Once he arrived at the bottom of the giant temple, he took a moment to look it over from top to bottom.

The design of the temple was unlike anything he'd seen before. The avian statues looked somewhat like owl-people, with stubby down-curved beaks and enlarged eyes. Their feathers were chipped and worn, showing how long ago the statues had been chiseled. Most of their color had long faded away.

The temple itself was fairly small, humble in appearance. It was only two stories tall, but the entrance was quite unique. It took the form of a doorway carved in the visage of some young bird-person, his mouth open, stairs leading into his mouth, and thus his 'belly'. The rest of the building was made of worn white bricks that were flaking apart and seemed like a man with a sledgehammer could pulverize the foundations in minutes.

The temple was, to be blunt, extremely shabby-looking.

But it also had an air of ancient majesty. At a glance, it appeared to have been around for countless centuries, perhaps even millennia.

Slowly, Timothy stepped into the entrance, climbing up into the giant bird mouth. He worried the mouth would slam closed behind him, locking him inside, but no such thing happened. Maybe he'd watched too many movies.

Instead, Timothy entered a dark room with only a single torch lit in the center. The room's interior was made of obsidian colored bricks that swallowed the light, making the room feel darker than it actually was.

Across the way, past that central torch, there was an aged avian man leaning heavily on a staff. His feathers were yellow, as if they had once been colored a brilliant gold, but had faded over time. He wore simple white robes adorned with a helix pattern on the front.

"Timothy Hiro." The old bird said, as he slowly began to shamble around the torch. "Been waiting a long time for you to show up."

Timothy blinked. "Ah. I'm sorry. Who... are you? Where is this place?"

"My manners, hoo-hoo. Forgive me, boy." The old avian said. "My name is... is... hmmm. I haven't spoken it in so long. It was... it was... bah, it's just a name. You may call me Old Gold. What is a name but a way to refer to another, hoo-hoo?"

Timothy nodded. "Alright then, Old Gold. So... who are you? Why have I arrived here?"

"The youth are always in such a hurry." Old Gold said, sighing helplessly. "You've only just arrived, and already you want answers. If you knew how long I'd waited for your arrival, I wonder what face you'd make. Hoo-hoo!"

Timothy frowned. "How... long... then?"

"Mmm... by your accounting?" Old Gold asked. He tapped his chin thoughtfully. "A few sextillion cycles, I'd wager. One loses track after a while. Of course, I'm actually supposed to be dead! So it's a miracle we've met at all, hoo-hoo!"

Timothy scrunched up his face. "You're supposed to be dead?"

"Indeed! I was dead!" Old Gold answered. "But then I wasn't. All thanks to the Great Shattering! Of course, I'm still technically dead, but when you account for temporal drift across the multiverse, it's a little difficult to... oh, it's all so complicated. Come, walk with me, boy. Let's go have a seat in the living room."

Timothy followed Old Gold deeper into the temple. The first room they passed nearly made Timothy's eyes pop out of his head.

"What the... how is this room so big?! The temple looked way smaller from outside! And are those spaceships?? I've never seen anything like them before."

"Yes, yes, it's just the hangar bay. None of the craft work anymore." Old Gold grumbled. "Not that there's anywhere to go. The whole universe is gone. I only managed to maintain a micro-voidspace for all these years because I was waiting on you to show up. Once we've had our little discussion, I'll finally let this space collapse, and then I can join the rest in quiet, peaceful *death*."

Timothy's heart jumped. The old bird was planning to die? And what was that about a dead universe? Not to mention a *multiverse*??

Old Gold took Timothy through a gigantic laboratory filled with magical and technological tools and weapons he couldn't wrap his mind around. They seemed so

advanced that even the Volgrim were like cavemen by comparison. If his mother could get her hand on just one of these-

"Don't bother stealing, and don't ask for them." Old Gold said, seemingly reading Timothy's mind. "If you try to take them back to your timestream, they'll explode. Kaboom! Wipe fifteen star-systems off the map. Besides, you primitives aren't moral enough to be worthy of my people's weapons."

"Your people?" Timothy asked. "Who are they?"

Old Gold thought for a moment.

"Hmm. Hoo-hoo, my people? We are the... we were the... oh, what did we call ourselves? I can't remember. It's been a long time, you know! You can just call us the... Birdos! Birdzos? Birazos? Bah, just 'Birdos' is fine. We look like birds to you, after all, and a name is just a name!"

"I see, so you're the... *Birdos*." Timothy repeated with a frown. It seemed like such a lazy and inelegant name, casually thought up, it couldn't possibly be their real moniker. Timothy wondered if he could glance through an old book or something to find out what they were really called.

Old Gold finally led Timothy into a small, cozy living room. There was a fireplace crackling, and a comfortable-looking sofa made of feathers and ivory seated along with several chairs.

Old Gold slowly eased himself into one of the chairs, then gestured to a chair across from him.

"There we go, now that we're sitting, my joints won't hurt so much. Hoo-hoo!" Old Gold chuckled. "Alright, alright. Ask your questions, boy."

Timothy nodded. He eased into the chair, noticing it was unbelievably comfortable. He could easily fall asleep in it if he were even a little tired. Luckily, he was full of energy.

"You said you'd been waiting for me. Why?" Timothy asked. "And what relation do you have with the King Network?"

Old Gold squinted his eyes. "The King Network...? Oh, you mean the *Creation Network*. Hoo-hoo. Yes, I helped the Creator make it way back in the day! Before he became a Ruler. Then I died. Oh, but I didn't! Because then the Great Shattering happened. So I lived. But I will still die eventually. Can't outrun death forever, you know!"

Timothy was visibly lost. "So... you're one of... or the *main* designer of my power?"

"Mhm. Didn't know who'd pick it up. Was waiting for someone compatible to emerge for quite a long while!" Old Gold explained. "A really long while, boy! You sure took your sweet time getting born! But I guess you made it before my time ran out, so we're all good."

"This dimension is going to collapse?" Timothy pressed further.

"Of course. All universes come to an end eventually. It's part of the Akashic Cycle!" Old Gold elaborated. "My universe is from... oh, say, three or four Eternities before yours? It was destroyed, but then the Great Shattering happened, and it wasn't. So I was able to live on for a few quintillion or quinbillion cycles. Whatever, I don't remember how long it took! You lose track of time when you're just sitting there, waiting for some brat to be born."

Timothy's jaw slackened. He was getting a lot of incredible information, but it was difficult to make sense of.

"What is the Akashic Cycle?" Timothy asked.

"It's the cycle of life and death." Old Gold said. "Universes poof into existence. They live on for an Eternity. They contract. They collapse. Then, poof! Another universe. And so it goes, on and on, forever."

"Oh." Timothy said.

He sort of understood the concept, but this wasn't something he had really discussed with his mother. It was just something he vaguely understood because of Old Gold's extremely simplified explanation.

"So then... what's the 'Great Shattering'?" Timothy asked, afraid of the answer he'd receive.

"Well, the Akashic Cycle was normal. Then it wasn't. Now it's different. Except, it's always been different, and it can't be undone." Old Gold said, his tone serious, but his words seemingly jarring and nonsensical. "At some point, it changed. Except once it changed, it had always been changed. The multiverse came into being, along with the timeline explosion, and all that other fun stuff."

Timothy did his best to follow along.

"So you're saying... time was linear, but then... the Great Shattering happened? And thus, time wasn't linear anymore? But now that the Shattering has happened, time was... *always* non-linear?"

"Wow, exactly! You're pretty fast on the upkeep, boy." Old Gold praised. "If it wasn't for the Great Shattering, I wouldn't have found a crack between dimensions to build my Old Gold Hold! Great name, isn't it? Considering I just made it up! Hoo-hoo! Anyway, where was I? Oh yes, the timestream. Well, it always Is, and it always Was, but at any given moment, it becomes different depending on who observes it. But it's also always the same, and it's always different. See? It's all so very simple to understand."

Timothy was trying not to feel lost, but he was not his mother. A lot of these discussions went over his head. He made sure to remember every word Old Gold said though. He would definitely repeat them to his mom later, hopefully giving her good information to work with. If Timothy couldn't understand, maybe she could.

"So... what caused the Great Shattering?" Timothy asked.

Old Gold cocked his head in confusion. It almost looked cute, like the look a parakeet might give when it heard a strange noise.

"You don't know?" Old Gold asked. "Shouldn't you? Your old man made it happen, after all."

Timothy's heart fell into the soles of his shoes. "W-what? My old... man? My dad?"

"Of course!" Old Gold crowed. "Jason Hiro, yes? He's the most famous creature in the multiverse! Ever since he rewound time and became the first Temporal Traveler, it became possible for any old schmoe to do it!"

The blood drained from Timothy's face.

"My... my dad... he died! He died. But you're saying... he didn't die?"

Old Gold scoffed. "Oh, so you're messing with me, boy! Hoo-hoo! Of course the Wordsmith didn't die. He time traveled back into the past. How else would the Great Shattering have happened otherwise? Maybe you're not too bright after all."

Timothy didn't hear the last words Old Gold said. The light faded from his eyes, and he slumped in his chair.

The young man fainted from shock.

A few moments passed. Old Gold leaned forward and blinked.

"Eh? *What the heck*?! Since when were kids so frail?? Guess I'll have to put on a pot of tea and wait 'til he wakes up! Hoo-hoo!"

Part 761: Heroic Rebirth

Far-Future Era. Day 21, AJR. Hall of Heroes.

Blake navigated his way through the Hall of Heroes with the ease of a young man who had lived in this small and compact dimension his entire life. The Hall of Heroes was not particularly large, perhaps the size of a luxurious mansion on ancient Earth. This might sound sizable to a layperson, but it was actually smaller than even Chrona, its compact form helpful in stabilizing its time dilation at exactly 100 times the speed of realspace.

Unlike Chrona, the Hall of Heroes was stable and was not increasing or decreasing its dilation speeds as time went on, meaning its people were not facing a crisis they needed to solve. As such, they could focus on developing weapons and tools for humanity, as well as consulting on war plans regarding what to do in realspace.

For Blake, he was not so much thinking in a macro-humanity focus on this fine day, but instead, he was dwelling on the scope of his abilities and unlocking his full potential.

Blake ultimately had two powers. He could manipulate light, and he could manipulate darkness. He could form them into shapes, even primitive constructs, but those fell apart if he stopped concentrating. Thus, after consulting with his mentor, King Arthur, Blake realized that there was something extremely important he needed to do.

His brain needed an upgrade.

Blake wasn't an idiot, but he fell far short of his older sister, even comparing her to when she was his age. Mandy was obsessive, possibly autistic, and definitely a loner who hyper-fixated on specific interests. Comparatively, Blake was a much simpler-minded guy who had a broad range of interests, was relatively charismatic, and was only interested in furthering his powers due to the pressures of the outside world increasing on his back over time.

Humanity was not in a good place. Its Wordsmiths were gone, and now their children had to step up and become the Heroes of the next generation.

It was a tough gig, but Blake felt he had to try and do something, anything, *everything* in his power to improve himself. Only in this way could he lessen the burden his sister and brother were feeling.

Blake made his way toward Solomon's Library. This was a compact room Solomon had made while his soul was still alive, a place where he had written and compiled all of his knowledge into different books throughout the library.

Sadly, Solomon wasn't able to finish his work. A third of the library's shelves were empty, and many of the books he had written were only half completed.

Blake had wandered into the library a few years ago, back when he was 15. He asked Solomon at the time what was the point of writing down all the books when his Crown contained all of Solomon's knowledge anyway.

Solomon had smiled at Blake. "The knowledge in my crown consists of septillions of individual memories, young man. It is vast and unfiltered. Those who are talented may tap into my crown, as Phoebe Hiro once did, and use their abilities to sift through the information to obtain unique insights. But these memories come from countless people and are nearly impossible for a layman to meaningfully parse."

Solomon continued. "One might be capable of learning a trade by reading through a volume of encyclopedias, but the task is formidable, difficult, and far less informative than if the relevant knowledge were to be distilled down into the most important information. At the same time, self-learning is much less effective than a structured learning environment, preferably facilitated by an adept teacher."

"Thus," Solomon concluded, "my library is intended to be a distillation of important knowledge using my own unique insights, gathered over thousands of years. Rather than learning from raw unfiltered knowledge, I have organized the books here according to various disciplines, shifted the information inside to start with the easiest fundamentals, and tailored the concepts to grow much more difficult in scope as the books progress. In the end, if one is able to pluck a book off my shelves and learn a new skill within a week or two, my efforts will not have gone unrewarded."

This was the crux of Solomon's late-life work. Blake had flipped through the books on many occasions, but never had he been able to fully grasp a discipline with the ease his sister had mastered Runecrafting, or Elizabeth Kindelmann had become a renowned blacksmith.

On this day, Blake walked into the library and perused the shelves as he had many times in the past. The room was empty, even a little eerie. The shelves were made of wood, but they also had all sorts of tacky gold and jewels encrusted onto their edges in

ornate patterns to 'spruce them up' as Solomon would say. Chandeliers hung from the ceiling, embedded with multi-colored stones that glowed and gave off light of all different hues. The final color tone of the room ended up being a weirdly dark blue mixed with gold, so it always felt offputting to Blake, as well as everyone else.

Blake walked over to the fourth row of shelves. Several books jumped out at him.

APPRENTICE TO MASTER BLACKSMITHING: VOLS I-III

PAINTING AND YOU: DEPTHS OF IMAGINATION

THE OPERATIC ARTS: PROJECTING YOUR VOICE

THE OPERATIC ARTS: A PRESENCE TO AWE NATIONS

ANCIENT EARTH MARTIAL ARTS: FENCING

ANCIENT EARTH MARTIAL ARTS: TAIJUTSU

SHIPBUILDING: NAVAL CONSTRUCTION ACROSS HISTORY

GOLD AND JEWELS: HOW WEALTH AFFECTS GENIUS

ANCIENT EARTH MARTIAL ARTS: TAE-KWON-DO

APPRENTICE TO MASTER CARPENTRY: VOLS I-VI

EXOBEAST TAMING (WORK IN PROGRESS)

ANCIENT EARTH MARTIAL ARTS: KARATE

One book after another was lined up on the shelf, not alphabetically or according to any particular arrangement. It wasn't as if Solomon had carefully organized the collection; he was planning on doing that only later, once the collection was finished. Thus, the books on learning trades were scattered all over the place alongside books about history, warfare, even hobbyist books such as the ones focused on painting and acting.

Blake ultimately reached for a book on painting. He felt that, as of lately, his imagination was the most lacking. He wasn't using his powers flexibly, and as a result, he was wasting his potential. Maybe a book focused on the arts would help?

He walked toward the center of the room. There, he saw Solomon's Crown levitating above a pedestal, three shafts of light pointed downward at it. Since Solomon's death, nobody had worn his crown. They felt it would be disrespectful, and aside from when Mandy checked to see if Solomon's soul was still inside of it, possibly reviveable, there had been an unspoken agreement not to disturb his well-deserved rest.

Blake stared at the Crown for a good while. He held the book in his hands and thought deeply about whether or not he should do what he was about to do.

After a few minutes, Blake sighed. "It's what Solomon would want."

Solomon was not a man who cared a lot about status, etiquette, or other social constructs. He was in many ways a utilitarian. Even though he had passed, Blake felt Solomon would want the next generation to use his crown to continue furthering humanity's growth. Locking it in a vault to preserve his prestige or honor his memory would likely be seen by the Knowledge-Seeker as a waste of the capabilities his crown offered.

And so, after a short few minutes of struggle, Blake gave in to temptation. He reached for the Crown and carefully took it off the altar. He placed in on his head and took a long breath.

Blake had worn the Crown a few times in his life. He knew he didn't have the affinity for it his sister did, or especially the affinity of his aunt Phoebe, when she was alive. The Crown was still universally useful to anyone, as it accelerated their thinking speed and cognition, but for those lacking in talent, it would only serve as a simple modifier to their base intelligence.

Blake sat down in a cushy golden throne Solomon had devised for himself and chuckled. Solomon was always so gaudy it made Blake cringe, but that didn't mean he took his comfort lightly.

Like this, Blake started to flip through the book on painting. With the assistance of Solomon's Crown, his reading speed drastically increased, and he found his brain was less mushy, but more pliable than usual. He started understanding the book much better than he could without the Crown, and as such, his enjoyment of the subject improved.

"Hmm... so Imagination isn't just a fun little way of day-dreaming, but it has real applications, especially in terms of magic. Interesting." Blake muttered. "Imagination equals mental visualization. Oh! Isn't this exactly what I've been lacking? I don't have a Mind Realm, but anyone can develop their Mind's Eye with enough practice and focus."

"Mmm, so drawing on three dimensional images in the Mind's Eye can allow one to better conceptualize the world around them as high order concepts. I think Mandy mentioned something about this with her runes, but I didn't understand it at the time so I couldn't add anything to what she was saying. What a shame!"

Blake spent a full hour reading the book. He didn't actually need that much time, but he read it cover-to-cover twice to make sure he understood most of the concepts. Unfortunately, he wasn't a painter, so a lot of the book's focus on color theory and artistic conception went over his head, but Blake found himself somewhat enlightened by even the shallow realizations he'd made.

After that, Blake put the book back. He wandered around the library, using the Crown to search for other books that would be useful to him.

"A book on 'video games'. I think dad mentioned those before. He said he used to play them on Earth. Looks like there's some good stuff in here about mental focus. I'll give it a read."

Blake picked up the book, then sat down. He soon became even more engrossed in the descriptions of games such as 'Pacman' and 'Mario' and all sorts of other games, with the book focusing on the historical progression of games, along with genres, mechanics, and how players could have a lot of fun playing with virtual characters in a fictional world.

"It's a lot like the Queenie." Blake said to himself. "My brother and sister both get to act like different people when they're in the Queenie. It's sort of like play-acting a role of someone else. It's a fun way to pass the time. But according to Solomon, there's more to this role-playing than meets the eye."

Blake read through the book three times. Solomon's highly detailed illustrations and artwork were beautiful and engrossing, to the point Blake wished he could play these old video games to see what they were really like.

"So playing a role isn't just about having fun, for one with a discerning mind, they can change their entire mental state to act like someone else. It's really useful for the art of deception and spycraft. But it can also be used for diplomacy, intimidation, and other actions."

Blake thought more on the subject. After a while, he became inspired.

Blake stood up, then activated his shadow-powers. He began cloaking himself in darkness, wrapping it around his body to form a sort of 'shadow armor' like he'd seen in some of those old video games. He walked over to a full-body mirror and frowned. He thought it would look cooler than it actually did. The armor looked... lumpy. He had no real conceptualization of all the intricate details regarding how armor was shaped, so it looked too squarish and blocky. The 'badass helmet' he had envisioned had weird and

disjointed spikes sticking up. They weren't arranged well, and looked like a little kid had put them together.

Still, Blake tried to get himself in the right head-space. He lowered his voice and tried to sound tough, gravelly, intimidating.

"Heh! Kid, you think you can bEAt me- *cough*! Shit! Why did my voice crack?! That was awful."

Blake's face turned crimson. He looked around, but luckily, nobody had heard him. As such, he returned his attention to the mirror.

"Heh, kid, you think you can beat me? I'm like, way more power level than you. Uh, I'm so strong, my darkness could block out the sky- the sun! Block out the sun. Blot out the sun, rather. Should it be *block* or *blot*? Uhh..."

Realizing his play-acting wasn't coming naturally, Blake decided to just drop the act. Instead, he started focusing on the armor again, using the mirror to try and shape it more clearly. But soon, he became frustrated by his lack of knowledge on the subject of armor.

"Damn. I don't have imagination, and my knowledge is lacking too. Maybe Solomon wrote a few books on armor?"

Blake dispelled his shadow-armor. He didn't do so intentionally, but maintaining it took intense concentration, and the moment he stopped focusing, it broke apart all on its own. That realization made him feel frustrated, but he also recognized he couldn't do anything about it at the moment.

Blake walked around the library again. He found a few books on metallurgy. They weren't exactly what he was looking for. He tapped into the Crown and found countless ancient memories of armies wearing armor of different sorts, but those thoughts didn't convey the knowledge of how the armor was forged.

"Metallurgy it is." Blake grunted.

He sat down in Solomon's throne again, then leaned back and crossed his legs as he began to read.

There was a lot of overlap with metallurgy compared to the books on blacksmithing, but metallurgy was about more than just making weapons, armor, and tools. Blacksmithing was a craft for creating equipment, while metallurgy was a science, focused on the chemical, physical, and atomic nature of the alloys themselves.

Blacksmiths focused on solid state metals, heating them until malleable, but rarely fully melting them or turning them into liquid. Metallurgy was all about examining metals and elements across the various states of matter, from liquid to solid and everything in between.

Both fields had a lot of focus on the changes in metal when under intense heat, but their goals were different. Blake found these differences to be quite interesting, even if the deep science went over his head somewhat. Alas, he was not a genius like his sister or aunt.

In the end, Solomon's observations concluded that metallurgy was based on the work of ancient blacksmiths, but both had their own uses, and it was essential that any aspiring craftsman mastered one and at least dabbled in the other.

The young man pondered Solomon's words for a while. He stood up and walked over to the mirror again, then tried summoning his armor. The result wasn't a lot better than before, but it was a *little* better. Blake started mentally reshaping the armor bit by bit, filing off the edges to make it a little more angular. It was still blocky, almost robotic, but compared with his first attempt, it wasn't too bad.

"I'll never be able to impress Psymin Miralax if this is the best I can do. Looks like I'll need to start practicing every day. I also need to find a way to manifest my powers permanently. Maybe I should talk to Arthur about that. His powers seem similar to mine."

Arthur wielded the power of light. Unlike Blake, he did not control any aspects of darkness, but his magical reserves, particularly when wielding Excalibur, were infinitely vaster than the fledgling dual-type Hero's, by a colossal gulf.

This made Arthur a specialist and Blake more of a generalist. Blake wondered how Arthur's mana reserves had become so formidable. Was he simply born with them?

Blake continued to read books for ten long hours.

His eyes started to droop. He yawned repeatedly, but he was still mentally fired up. He felt he had so much to learn, but too little time to learn it. Only if he became more diligent could he grow stronger, faster.

It was around this time when Blake was beginning to nod off that the hair on his body started to tingle. Blake jolted awake and looked around the room. He felt a chill descend

upon him, a feeling of being watched.

His skin prickled with goosebumps. Blake carefully set the book down, then stood up from the throne and swept his gaze around the library.

"H...hello?" Blake asked softly. "Is someone there?"

Blake was not alone. He could feel it. He could *tell*. His senses were screaming at him that a presence had entered the room, but he couldn't tell from which direction, or where it was lurking.

Blake carefully took a step toward the eastern door, but he thought he saw something hazy near that doorway, so he quickly backed away. Even in the brightly lit room, Blake felt as though he was seeing shadows that definitely should *not* be moving.

"Who's there?!" Blake shouted. "Show yourself!"

Blake quickly ignited the power of his light magic. He covered himself from head to toe in it, looking with gritted teeth at the hazy shadows that seemed to be slowly coalescing into... *something*. He realized with a start that the sensation he was feeling was eerily similar to one he had felt earlier in the day, after he spoke with Arthur.

Blake's light magic formed an aura of repelling around himself. He didn't know if a shade or a shadow-walker had somehow sneaked inside the Hall of Heroes, but the aura of the unknown entity was growing more corporeal. He could practically taste the mana in the air crackling on his tongue.

Blake conjured a sword of light. He narrowed his eyes and took a defensive stance, readying himself to lunge forward as soon as he could get a visual lock on *whatever* the thing in front of him was. His heart pounded in his chest. His stomach churned with indescribable emotions of fear and anger mixed with doubt and apprehension.

It didn't take long. The figure became more visible. It assumed the form of a shadowy bipedal creature, faceless, featureless, standing ominously just beside the doorway. It seemed to be looking at Blake, but it had no eyes...

"What the fuck. What the fuck." Blake muttered under his breath. He had thought he was slowly becoming a formidable person, but now, faced with some abomination from the shadow realm, Blake found himself rooted to the floor in fear. His fight or flight reflex had instead caused him to freeze. He was shaking so badly even his teeth started to chatter.

Several seconds passed. The creature took a shaky step forward, as if it were learning to walk. Its movements were wobbly and unsteady. It looked as if Blake could run at the thing and push it over, causing it to comically topple to the floor. But Blake feared this was a ruse.

After a moment's hesitation, Blake acted on instinct. He fired a bolt of darkness at the creature, a mere probing attack to test it out.

The energy bolt whiffed through the creature and struck the wall behind it with a loud *POP*! The lack of impact left Blake shocked. It was a ghostly life-form, intangible?

Blake sent another bolt of energy flying, this time of the light attribute. It, too, sailed through the creature's body without nudging it in the slightest. The creature took another shaky, unsteady step.

"What are you?!" Blake finally screamed. "What the FUCK are you?!"

His voice was loud enough that someone passing outside heard him shout. Barely five seconds later, Elizabeth Kindelmann arrived at the doorway behind the creature. She quickly looked into the library, alarmed. Then her eyes snapped onto the shadowy intruder and she let out a cry of surprise.

Before long, the entire Hall of Heroes had been alerted, and Levi showed up, along with Mandy. Twenty other Heroes joined them, including all the top figures in the Hall, taking up positions behind Blake. They directed curious and hostile gazes toward the monster, which had taken another couple shaky steps.

"It's a spiritual lifeform." Mandy quickly assessed. She examined the creature's runic makeup, assessing it with senses beyond her eyes. "It's not a ghost, or a shade, or a shadow-walker. It's more like..."

She trailed off. The others looked at her.

"More like what?" Blake asked. "More like what, sis?!"

At that moment, the creature suddenly tripped and fell, making everyone raise their weapons and direct looks of apprehension its way. But then, like an insect molting from its cocoon, the black and shadowy color began to break apart and dissipate.

Pale white skin slowly took over. A familiar figure became visible, laying on the ground, unmoving.

Looks of fear were instead replaced with a variety of emotions. Shock, horror, dismay, exultation, even delight. The most common emotion, though, was confusion.

Blake took a step forward. He lifted a shaking hand, as if trying to touch the figure that was now laying face-down on the floor, despite twenty feet separating the two of them. His pupils trembled erratically as a range of emotions washed through his body.

"D... *dad?*"

Part 762: Fish Out of Water

January 29th, 2021. Sarabiya, Egypt, 6PM.

A few hours earlier, Jason Hiro assumed the role of savior and freed all of Bahamut's slaves. In doing so, he erased a tumor from the world, and also passed on the power of the Sphinx to Phoebe Berthold.

Now, with the initial hubbub having died down a little, but with many confused, angry, and even fearful former slaves having come to the realization they were not living in the same world as before, many eyes were directed at the two new acting directors of Sarabiya. Those two were a pair of women, Phoebe herself, and Jessica Harper, the Great Builder.

Jason had been 'humiliated' when the intelligent and brainy Jessica had put the Archseer in his place and established her authority, sending him packing. After Jason left, Phoebe stayed behind with Jessica and started interviewing each of Bahamut's former slaves.

At least, that was the plan. It turned out Jessica was the one doing most of the talking, but Phoebe didn't have any complaints. She was just as clueless about the current state of the world as all the others they were interviewing.

One of the first individuals they interviewed was Vex, the demon who had been the first to volunteer for the new SIGIL armor Jessica had invented. Even though he was a demon, he had instantly switched to becoming Team Humanity in a single instant. Gaining the power of a Duke made his morale skyrocket, and now he was all too happy to please.

"You understand you may be made to do unpleasant things, such as killing other demons." Jessica said, staring down her glasses at the skinny, wiry demon on the opposite side of the table from her and Phoebe. "Demons are currently the enemy of humanity, and the enemy of the Heroes. By aligning yourself with us, you'll become an enemy of your own people. Are you sure you're okay with that?"

Phoebe glanced at Jessica. Her short brown hair accentuated her facial features, making her appear mature and imposing. At the same time, her eyes had a magnetic quality to them, Phoebe sometimes wished she could stare into Jessica's eyes for minutes

at a time, before shaking herself out of her stupor and returning to whatever task happened to be at hand. She had no idea why she possessed such weird thoughts.

"Kill other demons? No problem!" Vex shouted, sending a huge thumbs-up in Jessica's direction. "Demons already kill other demons. Who gives a shit if I've gotta kill a bunch more? Once my old buddies see how AWESOME this super-armor is, they'll either be smart enough to join you, or stupid enough that I'll just kill 'em anyway. I don't wanna hang out with a buncha morons who can't tell good from bad!"

"Are you only joining us because of the armor?" Phoebe interjected, directing a pointed question Vex's way. "That seems a rather flippant reason."

"Sure it's just 'cuz of the armor!" Vex immediately admitted. "What other reason do I need? You don't get my situation, do ya? Even if you didn't gimme the armor, do you have any idea what kinda life I'd be livin' in the Seven Hells, lady?"

Vex continued. "It's a shitshow out there. I had to scrape and beg for a hundred years just to get my first few souls so I could be a Grunt, and then I had to kiss so much ass I've still got pubes stuck in my teeth before I could become a Lord! And that was another 200 years! Ever since, I was stuck in a rut, nobody taking me seriously. It's a cutthroat life, living with the other demons! And I don't mean literally cut-throat, cuz I'd totally slice some necks if it helped me get stronger! But you gotta know the right demons or you can't go anywhere in life!"

Jessica nodded sagely. "I am well aware of the pains your kind endures. The Emperors kill humans, store the souls away, and only divvy them out to the demons they like most. With so many billions and trillions of your kind running around, there aren't nearly enough souls to go around. You're lucky you even made it to the rank of Lord in your lifetime."

"Damn right, lady!" Vex said, bobbing his head obediently to every one of Jessica's words. "But don't think just 'cuz I changed sides once, I'll be a floozy forever. I really respect that y'all are giving me this grand opportunity to be one of the first demons on your side! And furthermore, I've got a hunch that the old way of thinkin's about to change! I don't see the demons lasting much longer. I'd rather be on the winning side!"

"You think we're going to win the war?" Jessica asked, raising an eyebrow. "Just because of this single armor system?"

For once, Vex quieted down a little. He leaned forward and sneered.

"Sister, just cuz' I'm younger than most of the demon big-shots, that don't make me a dumb baby who can't tell his feet from his ass. I've seen lots of crazy stuff in the last 700 years. I even saw the short and sweet rise of that Joan Hero lady. You humans have always been waaaaaay behind on the military strength curve, see? But when Bahamut scooped me up a couple hundred years ago and I awoke in this weird future era, I started learnin' all *kinds* of crazy shit had gone down."

"The last time I saw you humans, you was ridin' horses and shittin' in canals along the street." Vex continued. "Now, you guys have these crazy metal machines, weapons that can kill from a distance, and flyin' machines are all over the fuckin' place."

Jessica nodded slowly. She had already done one quick and short remedial class for the newly awakened Bahamians, as she had taken to calling them, but she'd only gone over the broad strokes. She was surprised Vex had paid so much attention. It seemed that despite his sketchy attitude and skeevy manner of speaking, he wasn't as much of a nimrod as he first appeared. He was surprisingly bright.

"On top of ALL that," Vex added, "You have- how many was it? Like two Trueborn Heroes now and a dozen Lowborn in the wings? Even if you humans only had one Trueborn, with all these crazy military weapons you've been makin', I wouldn't wanna bet against ya, but now it looks like the human-demon war is a total wash! The demons are gonna lose, and they're gonna lose *bad*. It ain't a matter of 'if' but 'when.'"

"And you want to be on the winning side." Phoebe repeated. "Well, your motivations are self serving, but they're also oddly pure."

"I agree." Jessica said.

A long moment of silence followed. Jessica looked off to the side and fell into thought. Eventually, she turned back to Vex.

"Alright. Congratulations, Vex. You're the first demon we'll be adding to our ranks in the Divine Land of Earth. Someday, if you earn enough Merits, you might earn the right to see the Divine Land of the Stars. That will surely be an eye-opening experience for you."

"Just make sure you don't betray us." Phoebe quickly added. "Even if Jessica doesn't have the strength to chase after you, *I* certainly do. My Sphinx powers make that armor transformation of yours look like a toy."

Vex didn't even bat an eye. "Of course I won't! I'm a loyal backstabber, ladies! I'm on your side now, and I ain't changin' again! Now, you need me to sign a soul contract or anything?"

"Ah, no. That won't be necessary." Jessica said, before adding: "I already marked you and all the others as soon as Phoebe released you from the Sphinx's bonds. If you betray us, you won't be able to hide anywhere in the galaxy."

"Haha... ha... haha..." Vex laughed, his voice weakening slightly. "...noted."

Vex eventually got up and shuffled out of the room. After he left, Phoebe and Jessica took a few minutes to chat about various things.

"I'm looking forward to meeting the pureblooded angel, Almar." Phoebe said. "I've never spoken to an angel before."

"They're nothing special." Jessica said dismissively. "Some are better than others, and many are *worse*. Just don't get starry-eyed by his mere presence. That Almar seems fairly noble, but you never know with his *kind*."

"You don't like angels?" Phoebe asked.

"They're fine. Like humans and demons, there are scumbags and paragons among their ranks. I simply don't look up to them any more than I would an average human. I want to make sure you do the same so you won't be fooled easily."

Phoebe's heart was heavy. "Alright. I'll take note of that."

Before calling in the next person, Jessica glanced around the room. "Hmm, it's been a month and a half since you awoke... I guess now's as good a time as any. I'm going to do the rest of the interviews myself. Why don't I send you to visit the Divine Land of the Stars?"

"R-really?" Phoebe asked. "It seems like an awfully secretive place, Miss Harper. Are you sure it's okay if I go?"

"Yes. I want- err, I mean, the Archseer is interested in bringing you there so you have more time to grow and adapt to your new abilities... and your new life circumstances. Once you've been there a while, he plans to send you back down to Sarabiya to help me out."

"But we still have so many people to interview." Phoebe pointed out.

"I can handle the burden by myself, at least for now." Jessica said, waving her hand dismissively. "You're needed elsewhere. Go."

Phoebe nodded. "Alright. Thank you for everything, Miss Harper. You've taught me a lot."

After standing up, Phoebe paused and looked at Jessica's side profile. "Say, I've been wondering... are you and the Archseer..."

"We're not married. Absolutely not." Jessica immediately retorted.

"I was going to say... *related*?" Phoebe said, causing Jessica to blink in surprise. "You and him are sort of similar."

Jessica looked at Phoebe for a long moment, then looked away and chuckled.

"Saying we're 'related' is a fairly accurate assessment. I am Jason, after all. One of his soul-clones."

"What? You are??" Phoebe asked, bewildered.

"Yes. I was going to try and keep up the deception, but it doesn't feel right lying to you. My Wordsmithing allows me to create clones of myself." 'Jessica' said. "And alter my appearance, or theirs. So I made a female clone. This is actually not even a 'real' body. It's actually mostly mechanical."

"Mechanical?" Phoebe asked, cocking her head. "You're... not human?"

"Jessica is not human, no." Jessica said, looking at Phoebe again. "This body is made of a nearly indestructible material known as... well, I guess the technical details are a little much, but basically think of me as an animated statue with super strength."

To emphasize her point, Jessica suddenly slammed her fist down on the table and made Phoebe jump in alarm. The wooden table practically exploded into splinters and fell apart all over Jessica's lap before collapsing onto the floor.

A moment later, Jessica waved her hand, and the table's fragments abruptly flew up into the air and rapidly rebuilt themselves back into the original table in less than two seconds. It was as if an army of invisible carpenters were hurriedly jamming every last splinter back into place and super-gluing them at a speed Phoebe's eyes simply could not follow!

After that, Jessica fell silent.

"Wow. Incredible. You can even make duplicates of yourself." Phoebe said, looking admiringly at the 'woman' before her. She still found it hard to believe that this was really Jason Hiro.

But then, a thought occurred to her. "You are a clone... so that means, earlier, when 'Jessica' mocked the Archseer and made him look bad, that was actually a deception?"

"A ruse, yes. My goal is to make the Trueborn Archseer seem insignificant in brains and only valuable in terms of combat strength. In this way, the demons will think I'm a stupid idiot meathead and drastically underestimate me. Except, talking to Vex has shown me that I might be putting too much heat on my clones."

Jessica shrugged. "Oh well. If Jessica dies, she dies. I'll just make another."

A morbid expression spread across Phoebe's face. "Don't you think talking like that is rather... foul? Jessica, you're a person..."

"I'm not actually a duplicate of Jason." Jessica said. "I'm literally not. I, Jason, simply have a powerful brain that allows me to split my thoughts and soul into multiple bodies, controlling them all at the same time. Let's just say this is not my first foray into cloning, and I've learned from my past mistakes. Everything 'Jessica' experiences is something I experience, and anything she says is something I would usually say."

Jessica shrugged. "Anyway, yeah. I'd like to bring you to the Divine Land of the Stars now. Are you okay with that?"

Phoebe nodded dumbly. "Of course, my lord. I only live and serve at your whim. I would still be enslaved by Bahamut and an ordinary woman without you."

Jessica fell silent for a while. She lowered her eyes.

"You're anything but ordinary, Phoebe."

"What do you mean by that?" Phoebe asked.

"Someday, my words might make sense to you." Jessica said quietly. "That day just isn't today."

Another moment of awkward silence followed. Eventually, Jessica gestured toward Phoebe, and Phoebe's vision turned white.

One second, she was looking at Jessica.

The next second, she was suddenly inside a strange room unlike any she had ever seen before.

Phoebe found herself standing in a room with glowing lights built into the ceiling. There was a brown table and chair with white accents to her right, and the design of them was somewhat feminine. She looked to her left and saw a bed with a white comforter on top, its edges brown, as if the opposite of the desk's color scheme, yet the color coordination was impeccable.

She looked forward and saw a smaller sub-room with the door open. There was a rounded white seat of some sort inside, it looked like marble but was impossibly smooth compared to marble. Phoebe also recognized a 'sink' inside the room. She didn't know why that word came unbidden to her mind. Perhaps she had witnessed something similar when she was under Bahamut's control?

Phoebe eventually realized she was inside a bedroom. It seemed to match her stylistic preferences, too.

Was this...?

Suddenly, there was a faint displacement of air. Phoebe turned her attention to the young man who had abruptly appeared before her. She recognized him by his golden hair immediately.

"Hey, Phoebe." Jason Hiro said, gesturing around the room. "I decided to start you off small. This is your room inside Aevum. It's your entire house, actually."

"My... room? My house?" Phoebe questioned. "The design is... unfamiliar. It seems..."

"Futuristic?" Jason offered.

Phoebe nodded. "Yes, my liege. Futuristic. That is a good descriptor."

"It's just *Jason*." Jason reminded her. "None of that 'my lord' or 'my liege' stuff, please. You'll make me feel awkward."

"I'm sorry, Lor- I mean, ah, I mean... Jason." Phoebe said quietly, flushing slightly when she said his name so plainly. "It simply... doesn't feel right. I always addressed King Arthur as 'King' Arthur. Decorum is important."

"Well, maybe it was back then, but the times have changed!" Jason said, raising his voice an octave. "A new life awaits you, and a crazy world you're sure to be surprised by. First, let's start with a little tour of your new house, okay?"

Phoebe nodded. She followed behind Jason as he introduced her to the 'bathroom' with the 'shower' and 'toilet'. As she had previously guessed there was a 'sink' inside. The fact water came out of the metal piece on top startled her. And the water was so clean, too! It was as clear as a placid pond!

"This is a hair dryer." Jason explained. "It uses electricity to create hot air. You can use it to blow dry your hair after you shower or bathe."

"Amazing!" Phoebe gasped. "This *electricity* magic is truly fantastical. It's like the stories the seers used to speak!"

"It's not magic. It's... science!" Jason said grandiosely, before chuckling and lowering his voice. "Well, admittedly, I *do* use magic to create Aevum's electricity, so you're not far off."

"Ay-vum?" Phoebe asked, pronouncing the strange word carefully. "Is that the name for the Divine Land of the Stars?"

"Yes. Aevum is a place I built myself." Jason said. "It is not located on Earth. In fact, I built it amidst the stars."

"The stars... you mean the *stars*-stars??" Phoebe gasped, seemingly piecing together that the name was completely literal, and not merely a fun play on words. "We- we're out in the stars? Up in the sky??"

Jason smiled. It was really adorable seeing Phoebe get flustered over such a small thing. Her expressions were really cute in his eyes.

But then his smile faded a little. A weird pit formed in his stomach, because the Phoebe he knew would not be easily flustered by news of this sort. She was a scientist, and a veritable genius, far smarter than him. Seeing her regress like this... it made him remember his real wife, not the false image standing before him.

Phoebe noticed Jason's expression shifting between different emotions. "Jason? Jason? My liege?"

The unfamiliar term snapped Jason out of his momentary mental fugue. He quickly cleared his throat. "Ahem, didn't I tell you not to call me that?"

"Yes, Jason. But it's just that, for a brief moment, you looked so *sad*... it took me by surprise. Are you feeling alright?"

Jason forced a weak smile, but it didn't fool Phoebe. "I'm... I'm about as alright as I can be. Let's not talk about my mental state. There's a lot of other interesting things to discuss, after all."

"Okay..." Phoebe said quietly.

Jason proceeded to explain the general concept of Aevum to Phoebe. She struggled to follow along, particularly when he accidentally strayed toward certain high-level topics.

"This... time... trans...ference... shifting... I am sorry, my liege. I just don't understand..." Phoebe said, lowering her head in shame. She knew her stupidity was confounding. For such a genius like the Wordsmith to take time out of his day to teach her, and for her to learn so slowly, he must be feeling quite vexed. Perhaps he might even be debating whether or not he made the right decision bringing her here.

"No, it's my fault." Jason said, a stabbing pain in his heart. He reached out to touch Phoebe's shoulder reassuringly, only to stop halfway and retract his hand. "Temporal stuff is just... never mind. All that matters is that a day on earth means 365 days in Aevum. If you leave a year from now, you'll return to Jessica on Earth with only one day having just passed."

"Oh." Phoebe said.

That was all she said in response. Judging by the look on her face... Jason knew she didn't understand at all.

"Let's just look around the house some more." Jason said.

He took her out of the bedroom and showed her the kitchen. Phoebe started feeling dizzy due to all the terminology he threw at her.

"Yes... yes, Jason. I see. Re... free... free-fridge... rator... stoah-ve. Oh, knives? I know knives. Mixing bowl? It uses electricity magic too?"

"And this is a microwave." Jason said. "If you put a plate or a bowl or even a cup of food in it, you can quickly heat the food up! But be careful, if you cook things too long they will be really hot! It's best to use short timers and stuff. I'll be giving you an assistant to teach you how to use everything here."

Phoebe looked at the strange white rectangular cube. She felt dizzy. She was becoming so disoriented from all the futuristic jargon that she started to wobble unsteadily on her feet.

"So next, we have- Phoebe? Hey, Phoebe! Are you okay??" Jason asked, before quickly reaching out and grabbing Phoebe's shoulder right as she started to fall.

"Uhh..." Phoebe said, as the world started to shift unsteadily around her. The next thing she knew, she saw the counter rushing toward her face, before she stopped just short of slamming her teeth against it.

Jason had, fortunately, managed to catch her before she fell. He carefully wrapped an arm around Phoebe's shoulder and eased her to the ground, looking at her with deep concern.

"Phoebe? Hey, Phoebe... are you okay? **Normalize.**"

A Word of Power escaped Jason's lips. Phoebe's vision cleared up and she found herself in Jason's arms, sitting in a heap on the floor.

"Huh? I- I'm sorry!" Phoebe cried out in embarrassment. "I suddenly felt faint, and I, I just- I'm so sorry, my liege!"

Jason carefully let go of Phoebe's shoulder. He pulled away and looked at her for a few long moments.

Then he sighed.

"No... I'm sorry. I'm rushing you through all of this. There's so much to learn, it was probably too much for you."

Phoebe balled her hands into fists. She felt tears welling up in her eyes at her own incapability and stupidity. It was obvious she'd gotten flustered and embarrassed herself. Now the Wordsmith was really going to think she was an idiot and a fool.

"It w-was my fault." Phoebe said, fighting back tears. "I'm the one who should be sorry. I told you before, I... I'm not the right person for the job. I know you must be terribly disappointed in me, my lie- I mean, I mean *Jason*."

To her surprise, when Phoebe looked at Jason, she found that he was stifling tears of his own, and this was such a surprising sight that it startled Phoebe out of her own state of distress.

She simply couldn't understand why *he* would be on the verge of tears. If anything, she thought he would be angry, or maybe disappointed. Just what sorts of strange thoughts were going through the young Hero's mind for him to be... sad?

Phoebe might not be all that bright, but she was a quick thinker. It only took her a second to realize exactly what the Hero was thinking about.

He thought he had made her collapse, and he was feeling deep guilt!

That was what made the most sense. He was just a young man, after all, and seeing her faint must have made him tearful because he felt it was his fault.

Phoebe thought this was a rather silly reason for a man to cry, but it was also touching that he cared for her well-being so much.

Jason had told her in the past that he was hundreds of years old, but Phoebe didn't believe that was *really* true. Humans couldn't live forever, and they would definitely age as time went on. How could he be hundreds of years old and still look like a teenager? Obviously, he had been fibbing to try and look more masculine. No young man would want to appear weak, especially when they possessed such a formidable Heroic power.

But then again, didn't he say he had the ability to change his appearance? Hmm...

Phoebe was slightly perplexed. But all these chaotic thoughts intermingled, and eventually, she couldn't help but let out a slight laugh.

That's right, a laugh. She suddenly guffawed at the absurd realization that she had been thinking the Hero hated her, when actually he was feeling guilt and thinking she had fainted because of him. It was absurd, and it was funny!

"Hah!" Phoebe laughed, before suddenly clapping her palm over her mouth.

There were still some tears brimming in her eyes, but she was genuinely smiling, and this made Jason raise his head to look at her.

Now *he* was perplexed. Wasn't Phoebe about to cry? Why would she suddenly laugh? Was it because she saw him about to cry? Did she think it was funny he was about to cry?

The absurdity of that situation, and the fact he knew Phoebe definitely *wasn't* the type of woman to laugh at a man exposing his feelings, also made Jason stifle a laugh. Here he was, feeling deep guilt at overloading his not-wife's head, and now she was laughing, and that made him laugh.

"Hah!" Jason laughed too, making question marks pop up over Phoebe's head.

And thus, like this, their strange and awkward moment shifted gears what felt like ten times over the span of mere seconds, their emotions a turbulent roller coaster.

With Phoebe seeing that Jason was stifling a laugh, and Jason seeing that Phoebe was stifling a laugh, they suddenly couldn't hold it in, and both of them started laughing even harder. What followed was thirty seconds of uproarious confused laughter where both of them were laughing at each other and themselves. They were laughing for reasons they didn't even understand! Neither one knew what the other thought was so funny, but the comical mixture of tears of sadness and genuine laughter was like a tonic that shook them out of their stupor.

Jason grabbed his belly and roared so hard he thought he was going to throw up, while Phoebe suddenly got the hiccups, which made her giggling even funnier to Jason, and made him break out into another fit of laughter.

It took five entire minutes for both of them to stop giggling like little children. Even so, the residual giggling fits continued for another minute before Jason and Phoebe both managed to steel their faces, the corners of their lips still twitching.

"You... why were you laughing?" Jason asked.

"I don't know." Phoebe admitted. "I just thought... oh, it's not that important. That was such an awkward situation, I hope you'll forgive me, Jason."

"Yeah, it's fine. I was feeling guilty I made you faint with all my fancy words." Jason said, partially lying, yet accidentally 'confirming the truth' in Phoebe's mind at the same time. "Um, so, yeah. Let's just cut the tour short, eh? I think I can show you around without making you fall over from confusion."

"I'll try to understand better, Jason!" Phoebe said, once again turning crimson from embarrassment. It seemed he really had felt guilty about overloading her head! Phoebe cursed her tiny peasant brain for being so bad at understanding all his jargon.

Jason and Phoebe both got up off the floor and after dusting themselves off, Jason led her into the living room.

"Look, forget all that other stuff. This is the room where you'll be relaxing most of the time if you have nothing to do. I installed a TV with all the programs you'd ever want to watch from Earth on it."

Phoebe felt a hint of fear in her stomach.

"...*Tee-vee*?" She asked, wincing in preparation for another jargon-filled reply.

"Uh. You know what? Just think of it like a magical box." Jason said. "Have you ever watched a play?"

Phoebe nodded slowly. "King Arthur put on many plays in his court for his knights to enjoy, yes."

"Alright, well, it's sort of like that. A box with people doing play-acting, where they act out fantastical stories, all of them fake to some degree, as well as stuff like sports, where people play games where they try to earn points. Here, let me show you."

Jason sat on the couch. It was true that he needed to show Phoebe around Aevum, but starting with something a little lighter sounded better. Phoebe sat on the opposite side of the couch from him, marveling at how comfortable the cushions were. Wasn't this like a bed for the king's servants? She could only imagine how comfortable her own bed was in comparison!

Jason picked up a remote and turned on the TV. Phoebe jumped slightly when a man suddenly appeared with a strange object in his mouth. Phoebe hesitantly identified it as some sort of long burning stick... perhaps a drug of some sort? The man wore a wide brimmed hat and an outfit that was completely foreign to her. Then he took a strange metal object off the side of his waist, aimed at it another man and-

BLAM! BLAM!

That was the first time Phoebe had ever heard the sound of thunder coming from a man's hand. She flinched in fear, wondering what evil magic he had just used.

"This is called a 'western.'" Jason explained. "It's a type of movie where a 'cowboy' fights outlaws. Think of it like a futuristic knight hunting down bad people from back in your time. And that thing he just did? That's called firing a gun. He used a revolver and shot the other guy."

"He shot him?" Phoebe asked, her eyes as wide as saucers. "Is... is the other man okay?"

"Probably not." Jason said. "But remember, even though this looks real, it's all fake. It's just like a play from your time, with magical effects. The man you see is a... he's a play-actor. Even when he shot the gun, it was a fake noise. Real guns are *much* louder than that."

"They are??" Phoebe asked in bewilderment. She prayed she wouldn't start getting dizzy again.

"Indeed. Tell you what, it's been a while since I watched any TV. Let's just put on something a little more... mellow. Something to ease you into the idea."

Jason thought for a moment, which translated into dozens of minutes with his accelerated thinking speed. Eventually, he decided to put on the simplest sort of program he could think of, a nature documentary about the Amazon rainforest.

And so, like this, Jason carved a couple of hours out of his schedule to sit with Phoebe and watch a few programs discussing the geography of planet Earth. Phoebe was much less startled by all the novel moving images, and she became extremely enamored with all the cute and scary animals that were portrayed on screen. With a narrator slowly discussing the beauty of the world she knew, Phoebe quickly grew to enjoy the concept of 'the TV', though Jason knew better than to simply hand her the remote. She was *not* ready for that big of a leap.

"Wow... this forest looks incredible. I would like to go there someday..." Phoebe said wistfully after the documentary ended.

"We absolutely can, and sooner than you think." Jason chuckled. "But not right now. We do need to get to work. I just wanted to sit you down and ease you into life on Aevum. Because of Aevum's time acceleration, you don't need to worry about the state of affairs on Earth so much."

Phoebe blinked. "Yes... the time... acceleration."

Jason sighed. She *really* didn't understand high level concepts at all. It was extremely jarring compared to the Phoebe he was used to.

"Well..." Jason eventually said. "Are you ready to go outside and see what the rest of Aevum is like?"

Phoebe tensed up. Jason had already smacked her in the face with 8,000 confusing new terms and names, she wasn't excited to be hit with more.

Seeing the earnest look of excitement the young man was wearing, Phoebe had no choice but to grit her teeth and force a pained smile.

"I... can't wait!" She said.

"Great! You won't regret this!" Jason said with a big smile.

Phoebe prayed he was right. She was just a simple peasant girl, after all.

A fish out of water.

Part 763: Family Reunion

January 29th, 2021. Aevum, 6PM Earth-time.

Phoebe stepped out into Aevum's open-air for the first time. She was filled with trepidation at what she would see, but even so, she was completely unprepared for the sight she beheld.

The first thing Phoebe noticed was the sky. There was a sun shining above, but it seemed 'off' as if it was ever so slightly a different color from the one she was used to. At the same time, the atmosphere was pitch-black, not blue as it usually would be when the sun was out.

The next thing Phoebe noticed was a gigantic towering spire with glowing lines of energy that wound their way from the base to the levitating crystal at the top. Phoebe had never seen such a tall building in her entire life. Its sheer height was awe-inspiring and made her look at it as if a god had crafted it with the essence of the stars.

All sorts of strange black-metal cubes were levitating in the sky. Phoebe had no idea what they were, or their purpose, but they hummed with faint pulsations of energy, making her realize she had heard this 'hum' since the moment she arrived in Aevum; she simply hadn't noticed it at first because everything else had overwhelmed her.

There were many other buildings colored white and gilded with gold accents as well. The whole city looked a thousand times more fantastical than Camelot, to the point Phoebe started feeling a little lightheaded again. She quickly closed her eyes and massaged her forehead.

"Welcome to Aevum." Jason said, tentatively patting her back with the gentlest possible touch. "Just take a minute or two. Don't let the sights overwhelm you."

"It's... it's so... incredible..." Phoebe muttered. She opened her eyes and squinted while looking around. It was difficult for her to even put into words how fantastical this Divine Land of the Stars was. It seemed stars had been used to craft it, because what other materials could glow so brilliantly under a pitch-black sky?

Phoebe did need several minutes to recover her senses, but eventually, she and Jason started slowly walking out of her house through the inner city. Phoebe didn't know this,

but she lived on a piece of prime real estate that future Aevum-dwellers would kill to enjoy. Her home was part of a large manor that Jason himself also technically lived in, but he rarely had time to actually spend inside, as he was always busy. It was situated less than 500 meters from the Nexus Tower itself.

Years from now, many people would compete for the right to live in a place quite a bit further from the Nexus Tower than Phoebe's current dwelling, and she was totally ignorant on what that meant.

Not that Jason cared. Phoebe was his wife, even if... not really. He would naturally give her all the best he had to offer, as he would for his daughter and father.

"And this over here, that's the Aegis Womb." Jason said, gesturing to a large glass dome with an interior that went deep underground. "Have you ever heard of Heroic Artifacts before? Perhaps ones similar to Solomon's Crown, or Excalibur?"

Phoebe nodded slowly. "I have indeed gazed upon the King's Blade in the past. It was a majestic weapon."

"Well, the Aegis Womb is a special place that allows me to manufacture all sorts of weapons, artifacts, and other fantastical things of that nature. In the future, I plan to place many craftsmen and women in there, such as the legendary Elizabeth Kindelmann, or perhaps even you, if you're up for it."

Jason smiled knowingly at Phoebe, but she did not smile back.

"Jason, I often find your jokes amusing, but if they have any weight behind them, I must dissuade you of such notions." Phoebe said, shaking her head gently. "I am no master of crafting. My thoughts are slow and simple. I am a much better fighter than I am a thinker. It really seems as though King Arthur gave you a false impression of my abilities. I wonder what strange things he has said to color your view of me so incorrectly?"

Jason's smile faded. He wanted to say something, but he found it hard to give voice to the words.

What could he tell her? That not only was he a time traveler, but he and her knew each other in the future? That would only serve to confuse her, and then she might start asking other questions... and this could ultimately cause a terrible situation to play out. He didn't want to scare her or push her away.

Once again, Jason thought of perhaps transplanting Phoebe's future memories into her younger self, but he shook his head. It was a terrible idea.

Put another way, some might immediately leap at the chance to 'resurrect' their wife inside her younger body, but Jason knew from experience doing so would only cause her past and future memories to collide. It would be as if Phoebe were experiencing two conflicting realities at once.

Additionally, one's lived experiences were always far stronger than mere memories, even implanted ones that felt as 'real' as lived experiences. Those implanted memories would end up feeling foreign, like experiencing someone else's life by watching thousands of hours of bodycam footage. Phoebe would believe her personal memories over the new ones, every time.

Another option Jason had considered was mind-wiping Phoebe entirely and transplanting all her future memories up to the moment he died. This was feasible. Jason *knew* it would work.

But it was wrong. It was so, so very wrong. He would never do such a thing without past-Phoebe's express permission, and even if she completely believed in him and trusted him, even going to far as to eradicate her current self for the sake of a woman she didn't truly know, the guilt would eat Jason alive. He would feel deep shame, knowing he had killed the Phoebe of the past just to bring back his future wife, revived in a new body.

Even if it all worked out... could Jason really bring himself to do that? Did he *deserve* to do that?

Phoebe was dead. She had died in the future. Putting her memories in a younger vessel would not actually revive her. His wife had died, permanently, for good. He would only be cloning her, not actually reviving the wife he lost.

Philosophically, it was a Ship of Theseus dilemma. The most effective way Jason could think to bring Phoebe back would still not actually revive her, but a facsimile at best, and he would only be doing so to make himself feel better.

Thus... Jason was at a loss. He simply walked beside Phoebe, basking in her presence, yet feeling somewhat numb and uncertain of how he should proceed.

Jason considered trying to romance her younger self. He thought about possibly making her fall in love with him without using magic or anything else, simply trying to

pursue her earnestly as any ordinary man would.

But even that... even that felt like a sin.

He didn't deserve to have Phoebe back. He had failed his wife in the future. What right did he have to love her younger, more naive self? What right did he have to cheat on the woman he'd failed with a version of her who didn't know any better?

Wouldn't he just end up killing her again? That was the only thing he was good at. Killing the people he loved.

Jason forced himself to remain stoic. This time, he carefully made sure his face didn't reveal any conflicting thoughts. He shoved all his concerns and worries to the back of his mind.

He opted not to think about the matter. It was easier that way.

"Over here, these are the dormitories of several young new Lowborn I've recently brought to Aevum to train." Jason said, gesturing to a large apartment building about ten blocks from Phoebe's manor. "It's also where my... my daughter lives."

"Oh, your daughter?" Phoebe questioned with a smile. "I remember you mentioned her. What was her name again?"

"...Daisy." Jason said, steeling his heart. "Her mother chose the name."

"It's a beautiful name indeed." Phoebe nodded. "If I had a daughter, I'd definitely name her after a flower. Maybe something like 'Lily' or 'Rose'. Can I meet your little girl? Is that okay?"

Jason slowed to a stop outside the dorms. He gave Phoebe a long look.

"Ah... Phoebe... if my daughter acts weird toward you... I would like to apologize in advance."

"Apologize? There's no need for that." Phoebe said, laughing off his concerns. "Kids will be kids. They say the darnedest things."

"No, I mean, she um... well, she was traumatized at a young age. I told you I was married before, yes? Well, Daisy , she... she lost her mother when she was only 6 years old. You look... a lot like her mother. So I don't know how she'll react."

Phoebe blinked.

She looked a lot like Daisy's mother? So didn't that mean she looked a lot like Jason's late wife?

For a brief moment, several thoughts clicked into place. Could this be why Jason was so interested in her? Did he fancy the only female Knight of the Round Table because Phoebe resembled his fallen wife?

Phoebe internally shook her head. The idea wasn't entirely far-fetched, but Jason had clearly maintained his distance from her all this time. It seemed he was even hesitant to touch her. And that made sense, given she was in her 30's and he was still a young man. What young man would be interested in a woman well past the beauty of her youth? He should be pursuing pretty girls his own age.

Phoebe shook off the extraneous thoughts. She simply nodded. "If Daisy says anything discourteous, rest assured I won't hold her words against her. A girl who has lost her mother is a sad child indeed."

"Yeah." Jason said.

That was all he managed to get out. His thoughts felt distant, disoriented. He was having a hard time emotionally coming to grips with what he had to do, but introducing Daisy and Phoebe was necessary if the two of them were both going to live in Aevum. Better to meet now than by accident when Daisy was unprepared.

After steeling his mind, Jason stepped toward the dormitory, his movements somewhat wooden. Phoebe walked beside him, but even she could tell he was having a hard time. He wasn't able to mask his emotions as well as he wanted, now that the moment of truth had arrived.

What's making Jason so nervous? Phoebe wondered. *Is he really that worried his daughter will offend me?*

After they entered, Jason led Phoebe down the brightly lit hallway. There were sounds of shouts in a gymnasium built in the basement one floor below the entry floor. They walked down some stairs where they heard a group of teenagers yelling and shouting. Phoebe looked on as a massive dark-skinned man was doing pushups in the middle of an open court. He seemed to be struggling as he lifted his body up, flexing at his elbows. His face was pouring with sweat, and his entire body was sticky from perspiration. He only had on a pair of shorts and some flip-flops, he was otherwise shirtless, and the observers could make out all the veins on his arms.

"Three hundred and forty two!" Another dark skinned man shouted, his back to Jason and Phoebe. "C'mon Jerome, you're almost to three-fifty! Tough it out!"

"You c-can do it, Jerome!" A pretty young teenage girl with blonde hair said. She clasped her hands together worriedly.

Another blonde girl was standing at the edge of the arena. She was holding both of her palms out, facing downward, and seemed to be struggling to concentrate, or something else. All her attention was on Jerome. She hadn't noticed Phoebe and Jason entering, even though she was facing them.

There was another well-dressed young man in a suit. He sat at a table nearby, sipping orange juice from a fancy glass. He only looked at the struggle in the center of the room with mild interest. He was the first to notice Jason enter.

Not wanting to distract the others, the suited-teenager quickly got up and moseyed on over toward the Trueborn.

"Jason! Good to see you again! And who's this lovely lady beside you?"

"Hey, Brian. This is Phoebe Berthold. Phoebe, this is Brian Bozzard. He's a pyrokinetic; he can manipulate fire."

"Wow!" Phoebe said in genuine amazement. "It's nice to meet you, Brian. What's going on in here?"

"Brian gestured toward the dark-skinned man doing pushups. "Daisy is using her telekinesis to push down on Jerome's body. Since he gets stronger every time he exerts himself, the harder he trains, the bigger his gains."

"Oh, I see- wait! *That's* Daisy??" Phoebe asked, looking at the pretty teenage blonde girl who was concentrating on Jerome. "She's your daughter, Jason? But she's..."

Phoebe looked at Jason with a mixture of confusion and embarrassment. Was Jason really not a teenager? Was he telling the complete truth when he said he was hundreds of years old? How else could he have a daughter who looked the same age as him?!

Jason met Phoebe's confusion with his own look of confusion. Why did she have such an incredulous look on her face? He'd already told her he was hundreds of years old. Could it be that there was something else she had misunderstood?

"Yes, that's my little girl, Daisy." Jason said. "Why? Is something wrong?"

"She's just... she looks to be the same age as you." Phoebe said, feeling dizzy yet again. "Are you really, truly, genuinely, hundreds of years old?"

"Yeah, I am." Jason said nonchalantly, as if that didn't fly in the face of everything Phoebe knew about the world. "What's so weird about that? Demons and angels are immortal. Humans can become immortal too, I'm just one of the first ones to figure out how to do it. I'll make everyone immortal soon enough, including you."

"Oh. Oh... I see." Phoebe trailed off, looking back at Daisy with a look of renewed interest. So this was the girl Jason had talked about so much! Phoebe had thought Daisy was eight to ten years old at most, not a young adult. And judging by the ruckus on stage, she was powerful, like her father.

Jerome looked like he was about to die. Daisy didn't hold back at all, and pressed down upon his back with the weight of a mountain. If the gymnasium hadn't been made of Wordsmithium, it would have collapsed from the sheer weight of Jerome's hands and feet crushing down on the floor.

"Three hundred and forty-seven!"

"Three hundred and forty eight! Come on Jerome, you've got this!!"

"Three hundred and... and forty nine!! You're doing it man, you're doing it! Just one more!"

Even Brian started to get excited. "Last one, Jerome! Last one!"

Daisy happened to glance over when she heard the unexpected sound of Brian's voice. At that moment, her eyes fell upon Phoebe's face.

What happened next was something Phoebe would never forget.

All of a sudden, the weight vanished from Jerome's body. Not expecting his trainer to suddenly retract her powers, Jerome launched himself skyward. In a single instant, his push-up turned into a springing motion, and he launched himself toward the ceiling, crashed through the gymnasium's roof, and flew into the sky. Jerome screamed in fright and surprise before Jason's fast-acting allowed him to reach out with a Word of Power and stop Jerome's momentum in midair.

Daisy was in a daze. She had become just as startled by everyone else when she lost control of her powers and Jerome flew into the ceiling, but at the same time, her gaze was completely transfixed on her mother's face.

In Daisy's eyes, her knowledge of Jason and Phoebe were not the same. Not at all. Once Daisy had mastered teleportation, she had secretly watched Jason from a distance over the years. She was familiar with what he looked like, and her memory of her father's face had never faded. She had thought of seeing him and speaking to him on countless occasions.

The same was not true of Phoebe. Until Jason explained to her Phoebe's situation and how she was under Bahamut's control, Daisy had never known where her mother was, or if she was even alive. Her childhood memories of her mother's face were blurry at best, and a source of deep anxiety.

Thus, the moment she saw her mother again, Daisy's powers went into a state of chaotic flux.

Daisy staggered slightly. She looked up at the ceiling, where Jerome had just gone flying, then immediately lowered her eyes back to Phoebe. Her previous work on exercising Jerome's body had completely fled her mind. She didn't care at all anymore. He had left her thoughts entirely.

Like a dream, Daisy stumbled toward her mother. She didn't blink. She couldn't blink. She looked at Phoebe with such intensity that Phoebe sensed the change in the young woman's demeanor immediately, but Phoebe was equally distracted by Jerome's flight upward!

"Oh my god!" Phoebe exclaimed, glancing at Jason. "Is that young man going to be okay?"

"Ah. Yeah." Jason said, as he saw his daughter approaching. He knew Phoebe had no idea just how important this moment was to Daisy. "Don't worry about Jerome. He'll be fine. Um, Phoebe *Berthold*, this is my daughter, Daisy *Hiro*."

Jason quickly put emphasis on both women's last names. He wasn't an idiot, and he had informed Daisy he would be bringing Phoebe to Aevum. Even so, it had been a few weeks in Aevum-time, and Daisy didn't know when Phoebe would arrive. Thus, Phoebe's appearance was, in every meaning of the word, a shock to her system. It caused a mental reboot.

"Mom..." Daisy said, as she drew closer. "Mom..."

"No." Jason quickly said, stepping forward. "This is Phoebe *Berthold*. I told you about her. She's one of King Arthur's Knights. Please mind your manners."

Daisy stopped a few feet from Phoebe. She stared at the white-haired woman, a wooden expression on her face. Her eyes were distant, as if drinking in Phoebe's appearance, yet unable to process the person she was looking at as a physical existence.

"Um. Hello, young lady." Phoebe said, now understanding that the situation was more baffling than even she had expected. "I... I'm a friend of your father's. More of a vassal, really. He explained to me that I look a lot like your mother, but... well, um... I'm not? I am sorry for your mother's loss. I'm sure it was very hard on you."

Daisy took a step back. She looked like she'd been punched in the throat. She opened her mouth to speak, but words evaded her. For several long seconds, he just looked at Phoebe with a blank stare.

"I... yeah... good... to meet you..." Daisy said numbly. "Sorry... I... havetogo..."

Before Phoebe or even Jason could react, Daisy... disappeared.

She vanished from the spot, as if instantly turning invisible. Phoebe was startled. One second, the young lady was there, and the next second, she wasn't.

Phoebe directed a frown Jason's way. "Jason... is there something you're not telling me? Your daughter looked like she'd seen a ghost! Is she alright?"

"She... she..." Jason said dumbly. "I... I should go talk to her."

He bowed his head apologetically. "Sorry, Phoebe. Stay here with Brian and the rest. I'll be back in a bit."

Like this, Jason also disappeared, leaving Phoebe with a group of curious teenagers.

It didn't take long for Jerome to return to the arena. He was angry and confused by what had happened, but he chalked the situation up to Daisy exhausting her power, causing all her strength to disappear. He didn't blame her for the accident.

As Phoebe was trying to figure out what was even happening, she heard a teenage girl's voice from her left side.

"Phoebe Berthold?"

Phoebe turned to look at another pair of faces she hadn't seen before. This time, there were two teenage girls, a brunette with long and curly hair, and another with short black

hair in a bob. They were both wearing cute dresses that seemed like they'd been made by a fashion designer.

"Yes?" Phoebe asked, not sure which one had spoken.

It turned out to be the black haired girl with a thin frame. She was somewhat homely, with a slightly sickly complexion, and she wore an eye-catching armband on her wrist that seemed to glow with magical energy.

"Hello. I'm Nadia." The black-haired girl said, before gesturing to the brunette beside her. "This is Sasha. She's a fashion designer, and an alchemist. I'm a... I'm a..."

Nadia struggled to search for the right words, but Sasha quickly interjected. "Nadia is the brains of Aevum. She's the smartest person here, maybe even smarter than the Trueborn himself! Nice to meet ya, Phoebe!"

Nadia looked a little embarrassed by her friend's boasting, but she didn't deny the claims. "I'm smarter than average, I guess. I'm just glad I finally get to meet you."

"Meet me?" Phoebe questioned. "Oh, that's nice of you to say. I'm nobody important though."

A strange silence followed for a few moments as Nadia simply stared at Phoebe.

"Oh. I see. Well, I have no doubt you'll become someone incredible, soon enough. Did Jason help you acquire the Sphinx's powers already?"

"He did. How do you know that?" Phoebe asked.

"Oh... I just kinda... know a lot of stuff." Nadia answered evasively.

"She's REALLY smart." Sasha bragged on behalf of her friend, yet again.

"I don't doubt that." Phoebe said, smiling gently. It seemed the young girl had self esteem issues, but she certainly did seem bright. Phoebe envied her intelligence. Nadia had a bright future ahead of her.

"Since Jason and Daisy both left, why don't the rest of us show you around?" Nadia suggested. "We can tell you about our powers, maybe see if we can activate yours as well."

"Sure. That sounds like a lot of fun!" Phoebe chirped. "And that Jerome fellow... he's alright?"

"Jerome is the toughest person here." Sasha said. "He can take a beating. You have *no* idea!"

While Phoebe was being led around Aevum, Jason chased after his daughter. It wasn't hard to find her, since she wasn't capable of teleporting out of Aevum, and the world itself was quite small. Jason's Wordsmithing let him blanket the entire realm with his consciousness whenever needed, part of its auxiliary functions he could activate with a single thought.

Jason found Daisy in her dorm. She was curled up in a ball in the corner of her room. The moment Jason appeared, her tears and cries of pain struck his heart like an anvil.

"Daisy..." Jason said softly. "I... I told you I was bringing her back. I didn't mean to-"

"FUCK YOU, dad!" Daisy screamed, mashing her palms against her eyes. She choked on sobs of rage and despair. "You ambushed me! You just brought mom in like that, didn't tell me it was TODAY! I wasn't prepared at all! And she was just THERE. She was right there, and I'm not allowed to hug her, or kiss her, or call her mom, and then you start getting pissy and reminding me she's not really my mom?! What's wrong with you?! How could you DO this to me?? Uuuu..."

Daisy's sobs became louder and more pained. Her heart beat erratically, and she lowered one hand to clutch her chest, feeling as if she was about to have a panic attack.

Jason instinctively wanted to use a Word of Power to ease her pain, but he knew that would be a supremely stupid move, robbing her of the emotions she deserved. Instead, he stood there, looking down at his little girl, not sure of what to do.

Carefully, Jason knelt down and reached toward her, but Daisy sensed his touch and slapped his hand away.

"Don't touch me!" Daisy snapped. "Fuck you, dad! Fuck you!! H-how could you do this to me?! My mom... she's right there... she's RIGHT there, and I'm not allowed to say anything? How is that fair?!"

Jason closed his eyes. He lowered his arm and became still.

He felt the urge to cry as well. Daisy didn't seem to know just how difficult the situation was for him as well, but could he tell her that? Of course not. He would be a terrible father if he made this about him. She had every right to be pissed, confused, and broken-hearted.

"I'm... I'm sorry..." Jason choked. "I didn't want to hurt you, baby girl. I didn't. I forgot it had already been a couple of weeks. I thought I gave you a heads-up and... and you'd be ready..."

"Well I WASN'T!" Daisy shrieked. "Just give mom back her memories already! What the hell are you waiting for?! Why are you torturing me like this?"

"I already told you." Jason said, his tone numb with calmness. "It doesn't work like that. I don't want to kill the past Phoebe to bring the future Phoebe here. And it wouldn't really be your mother anyway."

"She'd be real enough to ME!" Daisy said. "Just because you have some hangups about a stupid ethical dilemma, I'm not allowed to have a mom?! And what's all this about erasing her memories? She'd still be the same person, dad! So what if she loses a few hours of memories - mom is mom! She was the same person while she was trapped under Bahamut's spell, right?! So just make her real again! It's not that hard!!"

Jason hung his head. He had lots of good logical arguments against his daughter's words, but logic couldn't win against emotion. Jason wanted Phoebe to return just as badly as Daisy did.

"Your mother died." Jason said quietly. "She died. I held her dead body. What right do I have to clone her, only to make myself feel better? It won't undo the fact I failed her."

Daisy pulled her hands from her eyes. She looked at her father with a tear-stained face, her expression one of disbelief.

"That's what this is about?! Your *guilt*?!" Daisy spat. "So because YOU screwed up, fuck *me*, then? I don't get to have a mom?? Where's the logic in that? I don't care if I'm just talking to my mom's memories, or her soul, or her future self, or anything else! I just want my mom, and you have the power to bring her back!"

"That's NOT how it works!" Jason suddenly shouted, causing Daisy to flinch. "It doesn't work that way, Daisy! I can't just shove future-Phoebe's memories inside of past Phoebe's head. Put yourself in her shoes! Do you have any idea how bizarre that would feel to you?"

"I don't see the problem!" Daisy retorted.

"Fine! *Fine*. Then I'll explain it in a way you can understand." Jason said.

A moment of silence followed. Jason closed his eyes to collect his thoughts.

"Daisy. *Listen*. Imagine for a moment that a guy you've never met suddenly appears and says he's your husband from the future. Imagine he puts memories of a future you don't know in your head. Imagine that those memories seem *sort of* real, but they also equally feel like someone else's memories. What do you think would happen?"

Jason didn't give his daughter a chance to answer. "It would feel like you'd developed a personality disorder, as if two people were inhabiting one body! You would not *become* the person from the future, but would instead still be yourself, albeit with knowledge and thoughts and feelings that you never developed in person, all shoved inside your head! In the worst case scenario, it could lead to a form of mental psychosis, a complete break from reality!"

"M-mental... psychosis?" Daisy asked, feeling her heart sink.

"That's right!" Jason said. "Not only would we not actually be bringing your mother back, we would be hurting the Phoebe of the past, bringing terrible harm upon her. The only way to actually properly 'bring' Phoebe of the future to the past is by eradicating the memories of this Phoebe entirely so she loses all sense of self. But that would cause harm to her soul, and the transplanted Phoebe STILL wouldn't be your mother. She would ultimately just be a clone!"

"I don't CARE if she's just a clone!" Daisy said. "I just want my mom back, dad! Do the memory thing, just DO it! I know you can!"

Jason fell silent.

It wasn't as if he didn't want to do what his daughter said... but he and Daisy were different people. They had their own viewpoints on the situation.

"I can't do that, sweetie." Jason said quietly. "I can't bring harm to the Phoebe of this era just to sate our desires for a future that's disappeared from the timeline. That would be... the height of selfishness."

"Dad, seriously?" Daisy pressed. "You have to do something! You can't be okay with just bringing mom here and dancing around the truth! When she finds out, she's going to be so pissed anyway!"

"I DON'T LIKE THIS ANY MORE THAN YOU DO!" Jason suddenly shouted, startling Daisy and making her retreat into the corner. "You think I don't want my wife back? You think I like hurting you, making you look at your mother, knowing she's not really your

mother? Knowing I left you alone in this past, all by yourself, growing up in a hostile world?! Of course I hate it! I want nothing more than to snap my fingers and fix everything and get our happy little fucking family back together!!"

"D-dad..." Daisy said quietly, her shoulders trembling.

Jason inhaled and exhaled a few times. He looked away and massaged his temples.

He'd really done it, this time. He'd lost his temper and screamed at his daughter, the one person in the world he loved as much as Phoebe.

Jason felt wretched. Utterly contemptible. In that moment, he hated himself more than he did Gressil, Satan, Raphael, or any of the thousand other scumbags he'd come across in his life.

"I'm... I'm sorry... for yelling..." Jason said, as tears squeezed from his eyes. "I'm sorry, baby... I didn't- daddy didn't mean to yell."

Daisy fell silent. She lowered her eyes, a sinking feeling enveloping her mind and body.

"No... I'm sorry, dad..." Daisy mumbled, her mouth numb. "I shouldn't... I'm being... such a little baby... I can't... I don't know what to do."

Seeing that her father had started to cry, Daisy felt just as terrible as he did.

Without another word, she moved toward her father, then hugged him, and he hugged her back.

Father and daughter embraced, both of them feeling absolutely awful, neither knowing how they could resolve the situation properly.

They only knew they had to try something, rather than waiting for the universe to fix itself...

Part 764: Futuristic Feast

January 29th, 2021. Aevum, 6PM Earth-time.

While Jason was reconciling with his daughter, the Lowborn all gathered together to make Phoebe feel welcome. Phoebe appeared noticeably older than all the teenagers since she was in her thirties, so she felt a little out of place. Everyone around her looked so young and bright-eyed, she couldn't help but talk to them as if they were naive children.

However, one member of the group immediately stood out. Nadia seemed far more mature than her friends, in a way that was immediately obvious to Phoebe. She wasn't sure why, but Nadia seemed more put-together than her peers. While the other teenagers were energetic and excited to have what they initially assumed was a pretty new instructor lady, Nadia was a lot calmer and more measured. In some ways, she even made Phoebe feel like a student herself. It was a weird feeling, and it reminded Phoebe of how Jason appeared eighteen yet he had a wisdom far beyond his apparent age.

The future world Phoebe had arrived in was completely alien to the one she knew. She was struggling to adjust to everything.

"This is a cafe!" Sasha explained cheerfully as she dragged Phoebe and the others to a small dining area staffed by robots that Jason had made a few weeks prior. "You can order whatever food you want to eat. Everything is free!"

"Free?" Phoebe repeated.

"Yeah! You don't have to pay a dime for anything." Marco added helpfully.

Phoebe had a blank stare on her face as she looked at the small building before her. That was until Nadia spoke up. "You're probably more familiar with a 'pence' I'd imagine."

"Ohh, I see now!" Phoebe said, remembering pennies, farthings, and the like from King Arthur's era. She wasn't familiar with 'dimes' but she understood the concept of currency as a whole. Still, as a former Knight of the Round, she had never really had to worry about money anyway, as King Arthur treated his top knights with a lavish lifestyle for the era they lived in.

Sasha led Phoebe inside, and Phoebe squinted when she saw the bright neon-backlit menu showing all sorts of words for food she'd never heard of.

"Crow... crow-ton?" Phoebe asked helplessly, as one odd word jumped out at her.

"Crouton." Nadia said. "Crew-ton. It's French, little cubes of fried bread. Very tasty."

"I see..." Phoebe said. "Ham... buur... ger?"

Phoebe could read the words... sort of. They were written in the same English letters she had seen many times in her life, even if the styling of the fonts was very different from what she was used to. The problem was, she was completely unacquainted with modern cuisine. The words she saw meant almost nothing to her.

"I'll, um... I'll have the... soup? There is soup here?" Phoebe questioned. "With... beef? And vegetables?"

The robot behind the counter was a squarish metal machine designed to look completely inhuman. It stared at her with unblinking blue eyes.

"Yes. There is soup. Please state your preferred type of soup." The robot answered.

Phoebe touched her stomach. She hadn't eaten since emerging from Bahamut's enslavement. She was ravenously hungry.

Despite her hunger, Phoebe felt a weird pressure from the people around her. She felt out of place among all the teenagers, and she was awkward too, since she didn't know how to 'order food' properly. She'd never been taught, and she didn't know the etiquette, yet everyone seemed to treat her as an ordinary older woman who should know these things innately.

As such, Phoebe became flustered and started stammering. "I, I um... I would like some... meat soup please... with bread... and water?"

"Haha, meat soup?" Marco teased. "I'd go for the beef soup, personally. And what kind of bread do you want? Just plain bread?"

Phoebe went pale. "Bread. I want... um... yes, just... bread please. I um... I..."

What types of bread were there? Phoebe had never thought about it. Before she turned 18, she had helped her mother make bread a few times, but typically they just bought bread from the local breadmaker. He didn't offer different 'kinds' of bread. Bread was simply bread!

On top of that, once she turned eighteen and became a Knight of the Round after winning in one of King Arthur's competitions, Phoebe hadn't spent any time worrying about what sort of food she would eat. She would enter the dining hall every day, choose some food from the many platters made by the king's chefs, and eat with the others. She was poorly educated on the different sorts of foodstuffs available back then, let alone today.

"Would you like me to help you order?" Nadia asked, squeezing Phoebe's shoulder reassuringly while whispering in her ear.

Phoebe felt like an idiot. She was so embarrassed she almost wanted to cry. She hurriedly nodded, feeling guilty a young girl had to help her, but too ashamed to keep babbling like an idiot in front of the others. "Y-yes, please."

"Okay. So here are some things you might enjoy." Nadia said, pointing to some of the entries on the menu. "If you just want a little taste of home, try the chicken with barley soup, and throw in some garlic-seasoned rye bread. If you're thirsty, we can do water, or maybe a bit of some light ale?"

"Ooh, try some chocolate milk!" Sasha added. "I bet you've never had it before, and it's really good!"

Phoebe was still a little dazed, but sensing that the kids weren't going to make fun of her for being an ignorant dullard, she did feel a little better. "Um, okay. I guess I'll have that then. Chicken and barley soup, seasoned rye bread, and... chocolate milk?"

By now, even Marco, who was usually slow to pick up on social cues, had figured out Phoebe was uncomfortable and unaware of a lot of modern cuisine, so he didn't tease her anymore. Especially when he started to speak at one point and Nadia shot him a nasty glare, which promptly shut him up.

The other teenagers all made their orders. Nadia, Sasha, Marco, Jerome, Farrah, and Brian all ordered one after another, then they shoved several tables together and sat down together. Phoebe somehow ended up being sandwiched between Nadia and Farrah, with Sasha on Nadia's other side. The three boys all ended up sitting on the opposite side of the table.

"Oh, I see!" Brian said at one point, as Phoebe hesitantly explained her origins. "So you... you're a time traveler from the past then. Wow. That explains a lot. I do apologize if I or the others here have overwhelmed you."

"No, it's fine. It's not your fault." Phoebe said, blushing in embarrassment. "You've all been so nice. I'm just a little... slow."

"Slow?" Marco repeated. "No way! Anyone would be confused if they ended up in a crazy future world, where all the stuff was made of LEDs. Especially Aevum, with all its magic crystals and stuff."

"Ell-ee-dees?" Phoebe repeated, confused.

"It's, um... it's lights." Marco said, before sheepishly pointing at the LED lights in the ceiling. "Sorry. I'll try not to use weird modern words and acronyms so much."

"Oh. Okay." Phoebe said.

Before long, the group started engaging in small talk more, with everyone doing their best to explain anything Phoebe asked about, as she was extremely curious and interested in learning more about the world around her.

"So there really are machines that fly through the air? Like a bird?" Phoebe asked.

"Indeed! One of my cousins is a pilot." Brian said. "It seems quite the fun job, getting to visit all the different countries of the world. Of course, I've already visited many of them myself, since my family is quite wealthy."

"Job..." Phoebe repeated. "Is that a title? Like 'knight'?"

"Not exactly." Nadia explained. "You can think of it more as a 'profession'. Back in your day, you might have a man who cobbled together shoes for a few pence, right? That was how he acquired his currency. These days, people work 'jobs' that require an education before you can be hired. They pay you a set amount of currency per hour, or per day, or whatever the boss and employee work out together."

"Oh, I see..." Phoebe said, though she didn't fully understand the concept. "They aren't paid for each of the shoes they make?"

"Not really." Brian said. "In your era, one craftsman might make an entire shoe from scratch and then sell it, but these days, one man makes the shoelaces, a woman makes the bottom of the shoe, another individual makes other parts of the shoe, and a final person puts it all together on a factory line. Thus, shoes can get made way faster with people specializing in specific components of items."

"It's like that for almost everything." Sasha added. "The fashion industry is among the worst offenders. There are sweatshops assembling strings and straps and all kinds of little

components using child labor assembly lines."

Phoebe scratched her head. "What do you mean by 'child labor'?"

"Most people nowadays think it's wrong for kids and even young teenagers to have to work to support themselves and their family." Nadia explained. "Even so, kids are young and naive, so a lot of governments around the world tacitly endorse allowing children to do hard manual labor for far less money then an adult would earn. It's good for the economy, they *claim*."

Phoebe looked around the table. "What's wrong with children doing work? I helped my parents when I was growing up. I apprenticed under the local blacksmith, Sir Gregor, for a couple of years."

"Well, that's different..." Nadia said, before realizing something. "Actually, now that you mention it, up until a hundred years ago, it was extremely common for kids to work on farms for much of the daylight hours. So... I can see why you might not understand the misery of institutionalized child labor. Let's just save the discussion for later. It's a bit complicated."

Phoebe nodded. She was starting to feel tired again. Her mental model of reality was constantly getting rocked by the 'innovations' of the future era. On top of that, every time someone mentioned 'her time' or 'her era' Phoebe felt like she was an ugly old hag from the ancient past. It didn't make her feel good, that was for sure.

The food finally arrived, and Phoebe marveled as she looked upon the dishes everyone else had ordered. Her soup and bread was eye-catchingly plain and boring compared to the exotic entrees served to each of the teenagers at the table.

"What is that called?" Phoebe asked, looking to her left at Nadia's plate.

"This is Fettuccine Alfredo." Nadia said. "It's a Roman-Italian dish; noodles with butter and finely grated Parmesan cheese. There's lots of different variations and flavors too. Want to try it?"

"May I?" Phoebe asked.

When Nadia told her yes, Phoebe immediately used her fork to clumsily stab at the noodles. Sasha, sitting on Nadia's opposite side, giggled and told her to spin the fork to wrap the noodles around it. Phoebe took a bite and marveled at how delicious the

Fettucine was! She had never tasted anything like it in her life. It had a stickiness and saltiness she was unaccustomed to, but she found it delightfully agreeable.

"You should... try mine..." Farrah said, gesturing toward her plate. "This is spaghetti. It's really... tasty."

"It originated it China, and the red tomato sauce also originated from Italy." Nadia added helpfully.

"Wow." Phoebe muttered. "Italy made a lot of incredible food while I was gone!"

Phoebe reached her fork over to try Farrah's dish, but before the utensil made contact with Farrah's food, Marco suddenly cried out, "Whoa, whoa! You've gotta use a different fork, Phoebe! No cross-contamination!"

Phoebe halted, then looked up at Marco, completely baffled. "C-cross... huh?"

"You know, germs!" Marco said. "It's unhygienic to- oh... uh, well, maybe you don't... know about that?"

Suddenly, Marco felt like an idiot for even bringing it up. Phoebe looked at him as if he were speaking in an alien tongue. As embarrassed as Marco was, Phoebe was mortified that she had broken yet another unknown social faux pas! It seemed the future had all kinds of weird rules she had no idea about!

"N-no, it's okay..." Farrah stammered. "Phoebe doesn't know, and that stuff doesn't matter anyway. I don't mind... really... it's fine."

She smiled sweetly at Phoebe, but now that everyone's eyes were on her, Phoebe didn't know what to do.

"It's okay, I'll explain 'germs' to you later." Nadia said. "It's nothing to worry about. Basically, humans found out around a hundred years ago what caused most diseases and illnesses, and germs were the main cause. But since Aevum has many ways to cure all illnesses, we don't need to worry about any of that. Marco just isn't used to how Aevum works, that's all."

"Ohh, I see..." Phoebe said, her voice trailing off. She genuinely had no idea what 'germs' were, but they seemed serious! Since Nadia said it was okay to eat Farrah's food though, Phoebe didn't hesitate for long. She spooled some spaghetti noodles into her mouth, then let out a moan of pleasure when the salty and garlic-flavored noodles and sauce hit her tongue.

What an incredible texture! The buttery noodles with tomato sauce were so delicious, she couldn't believe they were real!

Embarrassed by his overreaction, Marco quickly made up for it by pointing at the food on his plate. "This is a 'hamburger'. Let me cut you a piece so you can try it. This is a really popular thing to eat. You usually eat it with your hands, but using a fork is OK too."

He quickly cut off a piece of his burger, and after Phoebe tried that, she felt like she had ascended even further to Heaven!

The kids here simply had no idea how good their modern food was. Phoebe looked at her simple bowl of soup and the plain bread beside it and grimaced internally, feeling like a country bumpkin for ordering something so plain.

The food of the future was ten levels above anything she could have imagined in her wildest dreams!

Nevertheless, after Phoebe sampled a bit of everyone's food, she smiled cheerfully at all of them, then went back to finishing the food she had ordered. Even though it was plain, the soup ended up tasting much richer and saltier than anything from her era. Even King Arthur's court had lacked most of the seasoning available to modern chefs. His greatest feasts were like dirt before the simple cafeteria spread these children had ordered on a whim.

And the chocolate milk! She never would have guessed a murky black liquid could taste so delicious!

What a future she had arrived in. What a future indeed!

"So, Phoebe, if you're not an instructor for us, then... who are you exactly?" Marco eventually asked.

Phoebe opened her mouth to respond, but no answers immediately came to mind. She stuttered and stammered for a few moments before blushing and lowering her head. "I... I don't know, actually. The Trueborn said I had talents and abilities he needed. Beyond that, I've no idea. I'm nobody special, despite what I keep hearing. It's truly a mystery to me."

Nadia subtly glanced at Phoebe out of the corner of her eye, but she said nothing. If Jason hadn't told Phoebe the truth yet, then Nadia certainly wasn't going to say anything.

"Oh, I think I know the reason!" Sasha suddenly shouted. "There's one obvious reason, really!"

"There is?" Phoebe asked, invisible question marks popping up over her head.

"Of course!" Sasha said, leaning forward to look past Nadia at Phoebe directly. "It's because... Jason *likes* you!"

Phoebe coughed, nearly choking on her food. She gave the teenager a weird look. "That seems a bit shallow for such a high and mighty Hero, don't you think, young lady? Besides, I'm much too old for him. I think you're more his type."

"Pffft, even if Jason were actually my age, maybe he's into MILFs!" Sasha said, before scratching her head. "Though, the M doesn't really apply, I think? Do you have any kids?"

"Me? Children?" Phoebe repeated. "I was a Knight of the Round. I remained chaste in service to my king. Naturally, I have no children."

"Ohhh, so the M doesn't apply, but that wouldn't matter anyway. Daisy told us her dad is hundreds of years old, so we're all like kids to him anyway!" Sasha said, laughing at her own genius.

"Sasha, come on, you're embarrassing her." Marco said, frowning at Sasha.

Phoebe was indeed a little embarrassed, but she was more confused than anything else. "What exactly is a 'milf'?"

"Oh, it's a acronym!" Sasha helpfully blurted out. "It stands for Mothers-"

"Mothers, Intellectuals, Leaders, and Friends." Nadia immediately interrupted before her best friend could blurt out something so uncouth. She pointedly stabbed some noodles on her plate and spun them around her fork before subtly glaring at Sasha.

"Ah, yeah, right. What Nadia said." Sasha laughed nervously, before quietly backing down.

"I see." Phoebe said. She sensed Nadia's reply wasn't entirely truthful, but she also guessed she didn't want to know the truth either.

It seemed she would have to investigate 'MILFs' on her own time when nobody else was around. Perhaps there was a library somewhere nearby she could do research...

The discussions continued, and Phoebe privately wondered if there was some truth to what Sasha had 'joked' about. Could it be the reason the Trueborn brought her here was

because he fancied her? It did seem odd that he knew who she was and he'd gone to such lengths to save her from Bahamut first.

But still, more likely, he had simply spoken to Arthur's soul. That made a lot more sense, and Arthur might actually have forgiven Phoebe, perhaps even recommended her as a trusted aide to Jason. It was a little far-fetched, but not *completely* outside the realm of possibility...

While Phoebe pondered these thoughts, she continued to engage in small talk with the teenagers.

Eventually, the food was finished, and everyone stood up to go. Phoebe marveled at the waiter-bots that swooped in and cleaned off the tables, then she and the teenagers headed toward one of the dedicated training facilities Jason had created.

"So, Phoebe," Nadia said, "Jason told me he would be giving you the power of the Sphinx. Do you have it now?"

"I do... but I don't know entirely how it works." Phoebe said with a frown. "I think if I make up a riddle, I can bind people to become my servant? But I have no interest in enslaving others, so that ability feels quite crass..."

"Just use it on demons then." Jerome said with a smirk. "Make 'em into your goons. Ain't nobody'll miss em. Demons are all pieces of shit."

Phoebe shook her head. "Sorry, but I don't see demons as inherently evil. I believe it is possible to reason with them. Maybe not all of them, but enough to make it worth the time. I refuse to treat others as my enemy just because of their species."

"Guess you ain't seen what demons do when they get the chance." Jerome retorted. "Rape, torture, murder, you name it. I had a friend from Kenya, said demons came in and destroyed his community. He barely made it out alive. Last I saw him, he was shootin' drugs in a back alley."

Phoebe blinked.

Shooting drugs? She wondered. *Isn't shooting what you do with a gun? And drugs, those are like tobacco and such... does that mean he was shooting tobacco into himself? Maybe into other people??*

She decided not to ask, leaving the question unresolved in her head. Modern slang had too many variations, and she couldn't understand all its nuances so quickly. She'd just

have to pick it up as she went along.

"My bigger point," Nadia continued, "is that the Sphinx's power is more formidable than you know. You now have the ability to transform your body into a powerful monster-form. It may even give you the strength to fight Demon Emperors."

"Truly?!" Phoebe gasped. "You're serious?"

"Indeed I am." Nadia swore solemnly. "Jason has spoken of other Sphinxes who possessed the power, and all of them could transform. If you can figure out how to do so, it'll make sense why Jason entrusted you with coming here to Aevum to train."

"Oh, then I would very much like to try it." Phoebe said. "What should I do?"

The group left the cafe and walked a few blocks over to a highly reinforced underground bunker where all the walls were made of Wordsmithium capable of tanking hits from even Belial, the hardest-hitting Demon Emperor. Even she would barely be able to dent the walls if she didn't care about injuring herself and went all-out with an attack.

The group formed a semi-circle around Phoebe, who stood along with Nadia. What Phoebe didn't know was that Nadia basically had access to all of Jason's knowledge, so she was quite familiar with the existence of Kar and Blinker in the future, but that didn't mean she understood all the nuances of what Sphinxes could do. Jason himself didn't know everything either.

"I suppose you should... um... look deep inside yourself?" Nadia said slowly, sounding hesitant for the first time since Phoebe's arrival. "The Sphinx transformation shouldn't require any training. You likely know how to transform innately."

"I do?" Phoebe wondered.

A long few minutes passed. Several of the teenagers offered their own ideas.

"You need to get really angry!" Marco shouted. "Like, you get all pissed off, and then your hair glows, and you go 'RAHHHH' and your power level shoots up, and then-"

"You watch way too many of those Japanese cartoons." Sasha interrupted.

"They're called ANIME, and they're ART!" Marco protested.

"Maybe it's... spiritual enlightenment?" Farrah suggested, her words soft. "Perhaps... maybe you have to start by seeking the mysteries of the universe, and then you find someone to truly love, and that lets you transform into the beast within?"

"*You've* read too many werewolf romance novels." Jerome snorted before smiling a little more softly at Farrah.

"Only a few..." Farrah said, blushing in embarrassment.

It was at this moment of indecision that Jason abruptly reappeared, teleporting in front of the teenagers and making them flinch. He had finished his business with Daisy, but she wasn't ready to see Phoebe just yet, so he came back alone.

"Did I miss anything?" Jason asked.

Nadia raised an eyebrow and crossed her arms, as if to say 'like you don't already know, you peeping Tom'. She didn't voice her thoughts out loud, and Jason pretended not to notice.

"We're trying to teach Phoebe how to transform into her Sphinx form." Brian explained. "Any ideas, Jason?"

Phoebe glanced between the teenagers. Now that she was more familiar with them, she noticed that each of their gazes held a different attitude toward Jason.

Brian and Nadia's expressions were extremely casual, as if they simply saw Jason as a fellow peer, an ordinary human on par with themselves. They didn't look at Jason disrespectfully, but it was clear they didn't look up to him as a godlike figure.

Jerome's eyes had a hint of fierceness, as if Jason were a rival he was constantly competing with.

Sasha also seemed a little bit fierce, like Jerome, but there was something else there as well. Passion? Hunger? It was as if she looked up to him as if he were an idol, or perhaps someone who could offer her a lot of benefits.

Marco and Farrah were a lot quieter and meeker in Jason's presence. There was a certain inferiority complex that seemed to make them ashamed to look him directly in his eyes. They both kept glancing away and smiling awkwardly, letting others do most of the talking.

By contrast, how did Phoebe feel about the Trueborn? She silently dwelt on her own feelings and found she fell on the same side of the scale as Marco and Farrah. She was more able to hold a conversation with Jason than they were, but she always felt overwhelmed with inferiority in his presence. He seemed to know everything, and since

he might actually *be* hundreds of years old (a concept she still found difficult to swallow), it did seem to give him an aura of divinity rivaling King Arthur.

Only the recent flub with his daughter and her fleeing had momentarily broken the image of an invincible man with the world help in his grasp, and that was a mistake Arthur could have made as well.

Thus, Phoebe realized she felt as if she couldn't be Jason's equal, and that colored how she looked at and acted around him.

After Brian spoke his question, Jason stood on the spot for a few seconds, then shrugged.

"I could force the transformation with my magic, but there's no need for that." Jason said. "What you need to do is learn to sense your internal mana. Now that you've become a superior mortal being, you have access to the same sort of magic that I do. If I forcibly help you tap into your power, it could become a crutch you end up needing to rely on, and that won't benefit anyone."

Jason waved his hand. He summoned a cushion on the floor, and a bunch of chairs around that cushion. He indicated for everyone to take a seat in the chairs, except for Phoebe, who he had sit cross-legged on the central cushion.

Phoebe wasn't embarrassed by becoming the center of attention, but she did feel a little out of place with everyone looking at her, eyes full of anticipation. If she let them all down, she might not be able to raise her head with any pride for a long time.

"We'll start with some basic meditation." Jason said. "I learned this from a spiritually-minded friend in the... *past*. First, you have to close your eyes and filter out all your external thoughts. You have to let go of your worries, and look within yourself. The Sphinx is a living entity, it has its own will that you must communicate with."

Nadia raised an eyebrow. She had said something similar, but it seemed even she did not have the full story on Jason's memories and who he was. Where she was clueless, Jason actually had a more developed idea of how to proceed.

Jason continued instructing Phoebe. At the same time, he subtly cast a few Words of Power on her. Phoebe found that, shockingly, she was beginning to lose her senses. She slowly sank into a strange half-dream.

The whispering of the teenagers faded away. Only Jason's calm voice remained. And then, he too began to fade.

Phoebe head swayed a little. She felt dizzy, even a little nauseous. The world of the living became a memory, and the darkness of her mind became more pronounced.

It was here, in that darkness, that she sensed a presence she had not detected before.

There was someone else with her… and the *entity* looked at her from afar.

[You are able to sense me?] The Entity asked.

Phoebe's heart jumped.

[Who are you?] Phoebe asked, her dizziness muffling her sense of alertness. [How are you in my head?]

[I am the Sphinx.] The Entity answered. [The last remaining member of my people. All the others faded from existence tens of Eternities ago. In many ways, I am little more than a lost memory myself.]

The darkness parted. Phoebe looked up into the sky of her own mind to see a barely-perceivable head floating above her. It was translucent, like a ghost, or perhaps a soul.

The head was vast in size, much bigger than her soul-form. But it was also substantially weaker, as if diluted and faded by the passage of time. It no longer commanded the rich vitality that the soul of a living entity would.

The head had little in the way of discernible features. Its most prominent aspect was that it was inhuman, animalistic, perhaps even alien in origin. It most resembled a white-maned lion, with drooping eyes and a face exhausted from a timescale Phoebe could not even conceptualize.

[You are the Sphinx?] Phoebe asked.

[I am. And you are the first Inheritor capable of sensing my true form in many an eon.] The Sphinx said, its tone neutral. It did not seem especially excited by the fact Phoebe could accomplish this, but it wasn't completely disinterested, either. The Sphinx seemed to look at her with mild interest. [For an ordinary mortal of no note to accomplish such a thing, there must be a spark of potential within you.]

Phoebe blushed and lowered her head. [I am nobody special.]

[That may be true.] The Sphinx said. [But such a judgment is not yours to make. Humility is said to be a virtue, but too much of it can become a poison to one's ambition. If you are to access the true power of my people's lineage, you must be able to puff out your chest with pride.]

The Sphinx manifested a little more inside Phoebe's mind. Its arms and torso became slightly visible, as if it were struggling to breach a barrier between the world of souls and the real world.

Flexing its arms, the Sphinx poked at the sky, causing a galaxy of stars to form.

[My people's story began one hundred and forty seven eternities ago, long before your Creator came into existence, or his predecessor, or the ten predecessors before them...]

Part 765: Sphinx's Origins

January 29th, 2021. Aevum, 6PM Earth-time.

Inside a place secreted within Phoebe Berthold's mind, the Sphinx grandly waved its paw, causing a spiraling image of the universe to appear. It was a spherical object of such size and mass that merely looking at the edge of its event horizon seemed to tug at Phoebe's soul, making her wince in pain. Within the orb there were hundreds of septillions of galaxies, each containing tens of millions to hundreds of trillions of stars and worlds.

The orb of light shimmered and spun with an unbelievable speed, like the molecules of an atom, containing such power that if one were to gaze for too long, they might become lost in delusions of grandeur, praying they could harness the power themselves.

[One hundred and forty-seven eternities ago, my people first arose.] The Sphinx said solemnly. [To you, I may be an unfathomably ancient entity, but in truth, I was far from the eldest of my people, the wisest, or the bravest. I simply possessed a gift of endurance that allowed me to outlast my peers.]

[I do not know my people's origins.] The Sphinx said slowly. [I do not know on what world we originated, nor do I remember the name of our home galaxy. I only know it was not Earth, and it was not the Milky Way, where you were born and raised. I come from a galaxy much further away than the one we now reside. Its name has been forgotten by me, along with the names of so many other prominent figures whose faces once took up a place in my mind. Sadly, the knowledge of who they were and what they represented has faded from my memories.]

Phoebe looked up at the spiraling universe grasped within the Sphinx's palm. She had no idea what a galaxy was, nor did she understand the true scale of the universe. But the concept of someone being lost and alone, far from their place of birth? That was a concept she understood well.

[My species is one that arose on our homeworld living as a symbiotic life form, primarily. Our home world was rich in intelligent life; that much I remember. My galaxy's Ruler bred us to be the ultimate life form... capable of jumping from host to host, each time gaining more power and increasing our fighting strength to a level our future foes

would surely not be capable of matching. I used the word 'symbiotic' to describe my people, but in truth, we might be better described as... *parasites*, feeding on the power of our hosts to strengthen ourselves.]

The Sphinx conjured an image of a world, one which appeared hazy and indistinct. It was clear at a glance that the memory of this world was so badly faded and poorly memorized that the Sphinx could only imagine it in the way a half-asleep man might remember a dream from earlier in the day. It had no discernible details, beyond possessing landmasses, a watery surface, mountains, and other bog-standard features any 'ordinary' paradise-class world might possess.

[Many formidable life-forms lived in our home galaxy, and all of them arose from the Seed World.] The Sphinx explained. [My people possessed the creatures of our world and Uplifted them to become formidable sentients before we spread out among the stars. We built ships of steel, with gravimetric warp drives and all sorts of other technological wonders that allowed us to colonize the stars.]

[I was born long after the spread of my people had begun.] The Sphinx explained. [Thus, I do not know the details of our origins, nor how long it took for us to populate the stars. When I was born, I was placed into the body of a host creature who became my first Bonded. I was born among the species known as Kessu, a species that came to define my current appearance. Earth is a fascinating world, one I have long observed through the eyes of my previous hosts, including the creature you knew as 'Bahamut.' It possessed many forms of life similar to the one from my home galaxy, and among them are the thousands of variations of creature known as 'cats'. The Kessu were similar to the 'cats' you know.]

Phoebe nodded slowly. Some of this went over her head, but she wasn't an idiot. She could roughly understand what he was talking about. The Sphinx looked a lot like a tiger, so clearly there were cat attributes involved in his physiology.

[Before I continue, I should clarify something important.] The Sphinx patiently explained. [I am the Sphinx, but that is not actually my name. I adopted the name along with the few remaining members of my kind, several Eternities in the past. We chose the name in honor of our fallen species. As for my original name, it has been lost to time. After the Devourer took the majority of my remaining essence, I lost much of my memories, and I became the pale shadow you see before you now. Faded, dissipating

slowly over time... I fear I may be the last Sphinx in the universe, but I have no way of truly knowing.]

"So you are not actually named Sphinx?" Phoebe asked.

[No. But you may refer to me as such. It matters not.] The Sphinx said. [I only wished to clarify so there won't be any confusion later. My species was the Sphinx, and I later adopted the species name as my own name, long after the majority had perished to the annals of history.]

The Sphinx continued. [In any case, while my appearance closely models that of my first host, that is only because of the deep bond we shared. My host inevitably died in battle, as did the hosts of so many other Sphinx over long, long periods of time. When that happened, I was saddened, but I adapted and jumped bodies into the being who had killed my host. Later, that entity also died in battle, and I jumped bodies into the next. And so on, and so forth, this continued until the end of my Eternity, the first Eternity where the Sphinx dominated more than one hundred galaxies!]

A look of pride gleamed in the Sphinx's eyes.

[My people were formidable. We spread out and conquered so many galaxies it would make your little mortal head spin. When our first Eternity ended, we entered the next Eternity a hundred times stronger, and conquered even more galaxies! Our rise seemed unstoppable! But alas, all good things eventually come to an end.]

He shook his head wryly, causing the hairs on his mane to softly wave, as if blown by a light breeze.

[I no longer remember what caused our downfall. I know it involved a civil war among the Allied Sphinx Consortium. I know that brother fought sister for dominance, and outside forces eagerly goaded the war along. Ultimately, the Sphinx Empire fell as other Rulers became aware of our abilities and found innovative ways to subdue us.]

The Sphinx panned out his paws.

[Listen well, child. What made my people so fearsome was our innate ability to jump bodies. You remember the power of King Arthur, yes? Of course you do. Imagine that he were to smite you dead where you stand. I, the Sphinx inside you, would jump into his body, taking control of a more powerful host! Or at least, I would have been able to do so

in the ancient past, before the Devourer took my essence away. Nowadays, I am little more than an errant soul passing my abilities on to the new possessor of my power.]

"Who is the Devourer?" Phoebe asked, realizing he had mentioned this entity twice.

[I wish I could tell you.] The Sphinx said, shaking his head. [When I entered this Eternity, I still possessed the majority of my ancient power, but I entered the body of someone too formidable for me to control. He seized back control, stole most of my abilities, and attempted to eradicate me. I survived only by feigning death and jumping to a new host, but my memories, my thoughts, and my very *essence* had been plundered. As such, I remember less than one percent of 'who I am'. In my prime, I could easily control the thoughts and actions of someone like you, let alone a weak little mortal such as Bahamut.]

Phoebe tensed up. She suddenly realized this Sphinx was not benign at all, and if he was telling the truth, she could have become his enslaved thrall if he were only a little bit stronger.

Luckily, the fact he was telling her this showed that he had lost all hope in restoring his power. He was only a faded memory of the Sphinx he once used to be.

After a moment, Phoebe's shoulders relaxed. "You... cannot control me?"

[Not anymore.] The Sphinx said. [Even if I miraculously regained my power a minute from now, I would not bother trying. I have long grown tired and lonely of existing. After the Devourer took my essence, I realized I no longer had the power to live on past this Eternity. As such, I have been looking for an inheritor to acquire what remains of my power.]

The Sphinx's eyes roved up and down Phoebe's body. [Jarnof was weak, servile, and inadequate. Bahamut was greedy, rapacious, and foul. You, however... *you* are quite pleasing to my eyes. I have looked upon the memories of your past and found you to be somewhat worthy.]

Phoebe's heart jumped. "Wait... no, I think you have the wrong idea in mind. I am unworthy, great Sphinx."

[I told you before, your humility seems a virtue in the eyes of other humans, but to me, it reveals a lack of ambition. That is the reason I took the opportunity to speak to you,

rather than immediately grant you what remains of my power. I still harbor doubts regarding your capabilities, or at least your *mindset*.]

The Sphinx frowned. [A Sphinx has the power to grant all of their abilities to a host, dying in the process. Few have ever chosen to do this. It does, after all, mean the end of our long-lived existence. My telling you this should make clear my intentions.]

"You want to die?" Phoebe asked in bewilderment. "But why? You said it yourself. You might be the last of your species."

[Either I am the last, or I am one of the last. The distinction no longer matters to me.] The Sphinx replied. [I am old, Phoebe. Older than you can possibly imagine. I have lived through one hundred and forty seven eternities. Think of it. You humans barely live to a hundred years. If each of those years was the length of an entire universe's lifespan, then I have lived as long as one and a half of the longest lived among your centenarians.]

That comparison shook Phoebe's mind. She lowered her eyes and stared at the ground, many thoughts swirling around in her head. It was at this moment she truly grasped just how unfathomably ancient the Sphinx was, or at least she grasped a tiny speck of understanding. She could never truly grok his current emotional state.

"So you are seeking an inheritor. Why?" Phoebe eventually asked, raising her head once more. "To carry on the traditions of your people?"

[No. Divines, no.] The Sphinx chuckled dryly. [My people have already been forgotten by the universe, save for the memories of the longest-lived Rulers still residing among the Cosmos. I don't care if my people are remembered anymore. If you wish to learn about us, I will educate you, but it is not my main reason in seeking an inheritor.]

The Sphinx sighed. [No, my reason is more boring than that. I may seem a long-lived immortal to the likes of you, powerful and mentally above the meager concerns of fleshly mortals. But in fact, I still have certain mortal inclinations that hold me back from terminating my existence. I don't want my entire life, my long long existence, to have been lived in *vain*. I do not wish to see all my accumulation thrown out like garbage.]

Phoebe was enlightened. "I see. So you think I would be a good inheritor, preserving what remains of your existence and even some of your memories, while you finally get to enjoy a peaceful rest knowing you left a mark on the cosmos."

[Good, very good.] The Sphinx praised, with the faintest smile. [It seems you're not the dullard you believe yourself to be. I sense there's more to you than even you know. Right now, you are not worthy of my power. But, perhaps knowing that such a reward is waiting for you someday, you may work harder, fight harder, and train your mind, spirit, and body to become a mortal worthy of my Gift.]

The Sphinx scratched a claw against his chin-fur thoughtfully. [I only gave a small portion of my power to Jarnof and Bahamut, as was the tradition among my people, but I did not speak to them or enlighten them as I am doing for you now. To be blunt, they were unworthy, especially that vile creature, Bahamut. Since I have shown myself to you, that should indicate in your mind that I am pinning a certain amount of hope on your future accomplishments, little one.]

A long pause followed. The Sphinx shrugged nonchalantly.

[Of course, you may end up dying, and I shall pass on to the one who slays you. Maybe they will be more worthy, or maybe they will not. The main reason I wish to find an inheritor is also due to one final reason…]

This time, the Sphinx paused for several long, drawn out seconds. His gaze became cloudy.

[The Devourer took my longevity from me. I am incapable of surviving this Eternity. I will perish at the end, no matter what. Only by finding an Inheritor can I potentially pass on my essence to the next Eternity, and the one after it, and the one after that as well. I will no longer be alive to 'enjoy' such an existence, but at least there will be the chance the heritage of my people continues long after I am gone. That is something worth celebrating.]

"I thought you didn't care if your people's heritage disappeared?" Phoebe challenged.

[I *don't*. Not in the abstract sense.] The Sphinx retorted. [But still… my weak inner self would hate if the Sphinx's legacy perished forever. Call it a selfish regret that holds me back from ascending my mind and spirit to the highest level, but I would prefer that at least a portion of our heritage survives.]

Phoebe sensed that her time with the Sphinx was drawing to an inevitable conclusion. This was the moment of truth, a crucial decision that would shape the rest of her life.

She did not rush into a decision. Instead, Phoebe sat down in the darkness, lowered her head, and closed her eyes.

She thought about many things, a great number of questions that needed answering before she could make a decision.

What sort of person was she?

What sort of person did she want to become?

Was she happy with the way her life had played out so far?

Would she be happy if it kept playing out in the way it had up to now?

Did she have confidence in herself?

These thoughts, and more, slowly rolled around in Phoebe's craw. She squeezed her hands together in a sort of praying position, but she did not pray to any higher power. She simply focused her mind.

After a long while, Phoebe slowly opened her eyes. She looked up at the Sphinx.

"What is your true name?" Phoebe asked.

[It has been lost to time.] The Sphinx answered. [Even I do not recall.]

"That's a lie." Phoebe said, waggling a judgmental finger at him. "The truth, now."

The Sphinx's mouth curved up into a smile. [Alright, so it's a lie. But my true name is too imposing for mortal ears. I worry it might make you faint from lust.]

"Try me." Phoebe said. "If I'm going to be your Inheritor, then I have to trust you, and I can't trust someone when I don't even know their name."

[Oh? So you're already thinking of accepting?] The Sphinx teased. [And you're willing to boss me around, even. It appears Phoebe Berthold has more of a backbone than she thought.]

The Sphinx spread out his arms grandly. [Very well then. Let me speak my true name to you, Lady Berthold. In the ancient tongue of the Sphinx, I was once known as...]

He puffed out his chest in a most braggadocios manner.

[**...ELRINHATHNELGORAMATHTANSUNGARSHIKUUL!**]

A long silence followed. Phoebe's jaw slackened slightly, and she looked at the Sphinx's pompous pose with dazed eyes.

"I... I... could you say it again? But.. maybe... a little slower?"

The Sphinx snorted. He lowered his arms and smirked at her.

[Impressive, isn't it? Such a beautiful name that you even want to hear its melody from my lips once more.]

"No... I just... I didn't even catch it the first time." Phoebe said. "Can you repeat it?"

[Of course. My name is Elrinhathnelgoramathtansungarshikuul!] The Sphinx said proudly.

"I still didn't quite... can you say it *slower*? Like syllable by syllable? It sounds like a lion is roaring at me. I can't make out anything definitive."

By now, the Sphinx had realized... Phoebe wasn't kidding. She really didn't catch his name at all.

[It is pronounced... ugh... how embarrassing... it's... Elrin-hathnel-goramath-tansu-ngar-shikuul!]

He paused before adding, [My mother gave me the name. It forms a song with the rest of my family name that means 'the handsomest cub who will grow the longest mane!]

"I'm... just... going to call you... *Elrin*. Okay?" Phoebe asked. "My mortal mind is... too limited to appreciate the majesty of your True Name."

The Sphinx scowled. It was obvious he didn't like the thought of his beautiful name being shorted to such a tiny disyllabic sound, but clearly the mortals of this era could not handle it otherwise. He ultimately relented.

[Fine. *Elrin* it is.] The Sphinx grumbled, crossing his arms.

"Elrin is a beautiful name!" Phoebe praised. "And to us humans, it's very easy on the ears!"

Elrin was displeased, but arguing with a mortal, especially his Inheritor, was beneath his stature. So he begrudgingly changed the topic.

[Now that you and I have come to an understanding, Inheritor, we should resolve the external situation with great caution.]

"External situation? What do you mean by that, Lord Elrin?" Phoebe asked.

Elrin raised an eyebrow. He couldn't help but think 'Lord Elrin' *was* a bit more imposing than he'd initially expected. It might be a bastardization of his true name, but...

it wasn't the worst sound in the universe.

[I am referring to the group of people who are waiting for you to emerge from your meditation. Jason Hiro and the other teenagers. Jason knows more about the Sphinx than he should, and that fact worries me. I fear that he may not be as benign an individual as you perceive.]

Phoebe frowned. "I don't know Jason very well, but he seems a nice young man."

[Hah! Young to me, maybe. But to you? Your grandfather would call him *great-grandfather*. Even if he truly is a few hundred years old, it is nothing compared to the likes of me. I can see that he has some sort of selfish interest in empowering you with the lineage of the Sphinx, I simply don't know what it is. In either case, it is not appropriate for my Inheritor to be taking orders from a mere mortal like him.]

Elrin waved his paw grandiosely. [As such, you will need to work with me to play a little trick on the Wordsmith.]

Phoebe's frown deepened. She leaned backward, as if slightly recoiling from Elrin. "A trick? I don't know..."

[Deception is but one pillar in the art of war.] Elrin said matter-of-factly. [Tell me, Phoebe of Berthold, do you have a master? And if so, who are they? Is your master me? Is it Jason Hiro? Or is your master perhaps your fellow humans, who you will use your powers to serve and uplift?]

A moment passed as Phoebe pursed her lips.

"I do not have a master. I am my own master. Anything I would do for the Wordsmith, I would do out of gratitude, not because I placed myself below him."

[GOOD!] The Sphinx laughed. [You're already starting to get the picture! If you had said I was your master, I would have at least understood a little, but even I will pass on to the next realm someday, leaving you alone. For one who will eventually rise to the heights of the universe, you cannot look up to another; only to yourself.]

Elrin looked off into the distance, his appearance as majestic as the midday sun.

[It is lonely at the top, Phoebe Berthold. Never forget that fact. So long as you live an upright life and stand by the principles you believe in, you will become unbreakable. None will be able to taint your mind with witchcraft or skullduggery.]

After waiting to make sure his words had seemed into Phoebe's psyche, the Sphinx nodded.

[Now then. We must deceive the others. You mustn't tell them you have spoken to me. Keep my existence a secret. At the same time, you must demonstrate your worth to those currently surrounding you. I will not allow my future Inheritor to live her core years as the lackey of another, be they Wordsmith or Archangel or Demon Emperor or otherwise. As such, I will be granting you a small taste of the power that awaits you, should you continue to develop yourself properly.]

Elrin smiled. [Someday, when you have fully realized what becoming my Inheritor means, you will be able to properly appreciate the gift I am planning for you. But that day is still far from today, very far indeed...]

Phoebe stood up, then bowed heavily at the waist.

"Thank you, Lord Elrin." She said, her tone solemn. "I feel more at ease knowing you are here to protect and guide me. I was feeling out of sorts before I spoke to you, but now I have a bit more clarity than before. I cannot allow myself to be perceived as a bumbling ignoramus. It would besmirch your good name."

[Well said, Inheritor.] Elrin replied. [Now then, to begin, I must reshape your Mind Realm. It is barren and lackluster, but it seems you've already awoken a small spark of potential within. Given time, it may have blossomed into an average Mind Realm, but that is simply not good enough for the one who will take up my mantle someday.]

Phoebe sighed heavily. She once again felt that she was continuously wading further and further into a river without any visible banks on the opposite side. She only prayed she would be able to cross the river safely and make it to the other side without drowning.

"What must I do, Lord Elrin?" Phoebe asked.

Part 766: A New Berthold

January 29th, 2021. Aevum, 6PM Earth-time.

The Sphinx spent some time enlightening Phoebe. Lord Elrin was ancient and wise, and Phoebe could tell at a glance that he was a shrewd individual with long term goals far beyond her point of view. When an entity had lived for 147 Eternities, even the length of a single future Eternity was less than 1% the duration of his entire existence!

As such, a mental map outlining Phoebe's immediate future potential was extremely simple for him to create. After taking time to get to know each other better, the Sphinx smiled down at Phoebe.

[You have more potential than I expected. Your brain is like a sponge; you soak up anything I teach you. I will continue to modify your Mind Realm slowly over the next several years, as this is the most stable and painless method of improving a person's mental capacities.]

Phoebe bowed her head respectfully. "Thank you, Lord Elrin. You've given me a future I can look forward to."

[We've only just begun.] Elrin said. [Someday soon, I will introduce you to the true power of my people. Our ability to bio-engineer life to surpass its limits is not something the other mortals you know would be able to easily comprehend.]

"Bio-engineer?" Phoebe asked.

[You are not yet ready for this information. You are already overwhelmed by all the knowledge of this 'futuristic' society you've landed in, primitive though it may appear to my ancient eyes. Too much information in too short a time will not serve you well, but will instead harm you. Better to try and take things a little more slowly so you are able to fully comprehend the Truths laid out before you.]

Elrin grandly waved his paw.

[You may go, now.]

Phoebe felt the darkness of her mind slowly start to fade away. A tiredness swept over her. She felt as if she had fallen asleep.

A moment later, she opened her eyes again. This time, she found herself back in the gymnasium where she had first started to follow Jason's orders. Phoebe raised her head and looked around. The gymnasium was... emptier than before. Almost all the teenagers were gone. Only Nadia remained, but now, Daisy was beside her as well. That was unexpected.

Nadia was reading a book and laying in a bean-bag chair. She looked bored. Daisy was sitting on her knees in front of Phoebe, staring at her intently. She had a look of apprehension on her face.

Daisy jumped to her feet shakily when Phoebe lifted her head.

"D-dad! DAD! She's awake!"

Phoebe flinched. She didn't expect Daisy's reaction to be so extreme. A moment later, Jason appeared beside Daisy and looked down at Phoebe. His expression didn't carry so much 'worry' in the way Daisy's did, but maybe a bit of apprehension.

"...Welcome back to the world of the living, Phoebe. Are you feeling... okay?"

Phoebe looked at Jason, then at Daisy, then back at Jason. Invisible question marks popped up over her head.

"Yes...? Is something wrong?"

"I don't know." Jason said quietly. "I put you in a trance to access the Sphinx's powers, but then you seemed to fall into a coma. I couldn't wake you up. If your vitals weren't stable and it didn't seem as if you were otherwise okay, I might have started taking drastic measures to awaken you."

He paused.

"Phoebe, do you know how long you were 'meditating'? It's been more than ten hours."

"Ten hours?!" Phoebe gasped. She started to jump to her feet in shock, but when she leaped upward, she accidentally launched herself skyward, gasping involuntarily as she felt the ground vanish from underneath her feet.

The ceiling rushed toward Phoebe's face. She opened her mouth to scream, but before a sound could escape her lips, she slammed against it like a bug against a windshield. Her body splatted as if she had fallen upward at terminal velocity, and then she immediately bounced off the ceiling and fell back toward the ground.

"Shit- Phoebe!" Jason cried out. "**Gah!**"

He didn't even need to verbalize a specific word. Jason instantly cast a Word of Power with a single syllable, catching Phoebe before she could slam into the ground. His heart pounded like drums in a parade, apprehension and fear written all over his face. A split-second later, he cast another Word of Power to analyze Phoebe's body and see if she was still alive, if she'd broken anything, and how badly she had hurt herself.

What he saw left him stunned.

"You're... you're okay?" Jason asked, his words coming out in a single breath.

"I am??" Phoebe repeated, as Jason lowered her to the ground. She touched her face and arms, trying to check for any pain, but she didn't feel as if anything was injured.

A long moment of silence followed. Nadia had already stood up and run over by this point. She looked Phoebe up and down.

"Wow. That Sphinx power-up is something else." Nadia said after a moment.

Phoebe and the others seemed to realize something. Jason examined Phoebe again with fresh eyes. "How... how did this happen? Your entire body, your skeleton, your muscle structure, everything has a higher baseline value than it did before. It's like you've become five- no, ten times stronger just by meditating."

"I... don't know." Phoebe said. "I, um, I closed my eyes, everything was black... and then I opened them, and this happened. I'm as clueless as you."

Phoebe carefully repeated the lie the Sphinx had told her to say. Since the Sphinx had empowered her, it wouldn't be right for her to betray his trust and reveal his presence.

Jason questioned her a little more, but he didn't seem to notice anything amiss.

"Bahamut wasn't a particularly strong woman..." Jason eventually said, as he turned away and started stroking his chin, analyzing Phoebe's situation thoughtfully. "She was merely an ordinary Egyptian slave girl during her lifetime. The powerup she got from the Sphinx wasn't too extreme as a result. But Phoebe, you were a Knight of the Round. It seems you had a lot more potential for the Sphinx's power to pull from."

Unspoken, in Jason's mind, he also thought about Blinker and Kar.

Kar was a crocodile, powerful in body, so when he became the Sphinx, he became as strong as a Demon Emperor. Blinker was already at that level, so it seems her strength

couldn't go much higher. The Sphinx must have raised Phoebe's strength up tremendously, definitely more than it did for Bahamut. It seems she's become a powerhouse, as I hypothesized would happen.

While Jason was debating the current circumstances, Daisy was just relieved her mother hadn't instantly broken all the bones in her body and died. What a tragic end that would have been!

The father and daughter were relieved, and they easily explained the situation away to themselves thanks to their future knowledge.

Nadia, however, was different. She looked at Phoebe with an outsider's perspective while also possessing Jason's knowledge of the future. Whenever Phoebe explained that 'all she saw was blackness', Nadia subtly shook her head.

She knew. She could tell Phoebe was lying. But she didn't say anything. She decided not to tell Jason.

"Mo- I mean, Phoebe, let's do a little sparring!" Daisy said excitedly, nearly blurting out Phoebe's 'title' of 'mom'. Luckily, she caught herself in time. "I'll go easy on you. Let's see if we can acclimate yourself to your new strength."

Phoebe was in a bit of a daze, seeing that Daisy's expression had changed so dramatically from the anger she showed earlier. She nodded along to Daisy's request. "Okay..."

Jason grabbed a pair of wooden swords. They were Wordsmithed so that they could not cause any damage to anything at all. Even if Daisy swung them with all her strength at a bug stuck to the side of a pillar, the swords would stop on impact, causing the bug no harm. As such, Daisy and Phoebe could use their full strength without worrying about hurting each other.

Hearing that Phoebe had awakened, the other teenagers returned. Some of them were a little bleary-eyed. Clearly, they had fallen asleep and were forced to wake up so they wouldn't miss the eye-opening spar that was about to take place.

Jerome stretched his back as he walked in. "Heard the new lady got stronger. Maybe me and her can do a little fighting, eh?"

"You're such a meathead." Brian Bozzard teased. "All you think about is fighting."

"Cuz it's what I'm good at." Jerome sneered. "Can't a brother have a hobby?"

"I just hope nobody gets hurt." Farrah said quietly, as she hugged Jerome's side.

"It'll be fine." Marco said. "Those Noodle-Swords are crazy. You can't feel a thing when someone hits you with one."

As the teenagers chatted, Phoebe and Daisy squared up in the arena. Daisy's heart was fluttering. She couldn't believe she was really looking her mother in the eyes.

When she heard Phoebe had fallen into a coma, she had rushed over without thinking. She was panicked and afraid, thinking she might lose Phoebe again. But now that Phoebe was up and moving about, totally fine, Daisy was at a bit of a loss. She had trouble adjusting to the fact that her 'mother' didn't know who she was, had no attraction to her father, and was basically a stranger. Daisy wanted to hug her, and cry on her shoulder, and tell her about everything she'd missed... but this women wasn't Phoebe Hiro.

She was Phoebe Berthold. A completely different person.

Daisy lifted her sword. *Even if mom doesn't know who I am, I'll make her remember me. Dad's definitely going to think of a way to bring her future memories back. He doesn't have the willpower to hold off forever, especially when he realizes we can still be a family again!*

Since that's the case, I'll have to leave a good impression on Mom. When she does regain her memories, she'll be so proud of me... she'll burst into tears! It'll all be worth it then.

Of course, Daisy knew that not having her mother and father for 12 years was not something that could easily be resolved, but she just couldn't bring herself to care anymore. One month ago, she had no hope of ever seeing her parents again. How could she dwell on the past when a bright future was waiting right in front of her?!

"Hello again, Daisy." Phoebe said. She pivoted her blade upward so the wooden sword was positioned right between her eyes. "I'm sorry about what happened earlier. I didn't mean to make you cry."

"There's no need for apologies." Daisy said firmly. "I was taken off-guard, but I'm not a little girl anymore. I'm a woman now. A strong woman! I'll make you see that for yourself."

Phoebe raised an eyebrow. The girl was talking so familiarly about Phoebe... just how much did Phoebe resemble her mother?

The poor thing. Phoebe was despondent, imagining the anguish and pain of separation Daisy must have felt. For a moment, she wished she really were Daisy's mother, if only so she could comfort her properly... but of course, a sweet lie was still a lie, and Phoebe would never allow herself to deceive someone.

Well, she did suppose a *little* deceit was okay sometimes, such as hiding Elrin's existence. But... that was different. She just couldn't elucidate why.

After a moment of silence, Daisy suddenly lunged forward. Her movements were swift and practiced. She was not a sword-user, generally, but she had been mentored by many professional trainers of several different fighting disciplines, thanks to her Uncle Vasily, who always gave his adopted daughter whatever she asked for, and whatever she needed.

Daisy slashed at Phoebe, and Phoebe seemed to be standing still, her body unmoving from disbelief.

The instant before Daisy's sword would have sliced against Phoebe's stomach, Phoebe rotated her body and stepped to the side. Daisy's slash missed by a millimeter, and she almost lost her balance as her target dodged at the very last second.

"Huh?" Daisy grunted, looking at her mom in shock.

She recovered and leaped at Phoebe again, using her telekinesis to enhance her movements. She was fierce and swift, and did not dare to take Phoebe lightly. If she ended up beating Phoebe too easily, she would simply apologize later.

At least, that was her rationale. It was what she expected to happen.

Once again, Daisy cut toward her mother's backside with an impossibly fast slash, but Phoebe side-stepped the attack with a sort of ease that could usually only come from a battlefield veteran. She didn't look at Daisy with any sort of smugness or condescension, she simply moved with such fluidity that it was as if she were toying with a toddler.

Daisy followed up with three quick slashes, but Phoebe casually ducked, dodged, and side-stepped the attacks, each time causing Daisy to miss her body with such a small margin of error that Daisy often *swore* she'd touched Phoebe's clothes.

But she hadn't! Jason and the others watched the fight, with many of the teenagers feeling confused.

"What the heck? Didn't Daisy whoop Jerome's ass?" Marco asked, ignoring the glare that came at him from his side. "Is Phoebe actually a really good fighter?"

"I wouldn't have believed this was possible if I didn't see it myself." Brian said with a frown. "I thought Daisy was unbeatable, but the new lady is really, really talented. She makes it look easy, but even Muhammad Ali wouldn't cut it so close. It's like she's deliberately using as little energy as possible to evade every attack to conserve her stamina while wasting Daisy's in much greater measure."

As surprised as the teenagers were, and Daisy, too, nobody was more blindsided and shellshocked than Jason. His eyes went wide. He had known the Phoebe of the future, and while she definitely kicked his ass when they were younger, Jason was 100% certain she had never been this monstrous at any point, even six years later, right before she died, when she was at her 'peak' as far as he knew.

Either she had been holding back in the future era, which made no sense, or her abilities had skyrocketed. The most obvious explanation was the Sphinx, again!

Daisy started to perspire. She attacked Phoebe over and over, swinging wildly, trying to feint and trick her mother, and she even started playing dirty, using her telekinesis to root Phoebe in place.

But nothing worked! Even when Daisy raised the gravity around her mother tenfold to try and press her feet into the ground, Phoebe's movements only slowed down a little, but she continued to effortlessly dodge her daughter's attacks with great ease. Her strength was great enough that the increased gravity didn't really affect her much, and only forced her to compensate. Daisy spent more energy focusing her telekinesis than Phoebe did overcoming it.

Daisy's sweating turned into heavy breathing. Pretty soon, she started gasping for air. She couldn't believe what was happening! Her mother was the one making her look like a fool! Daisy couldn't land a single hit!

"D-do you only know how to dodge?!" Daisy finally shrieked, pausing for a moment to cough. Her chest heaved up and down, and the back of her throat was fiery-hot. She wanted to chug a gallon of water just to cool off. She had never, not once in her entire life, been brought to such a state by merely attacking the empty air!

"Sorry..." Phoebe said slowly. "I don't even know what's going on. I'm not even trying to dodge you. I just keep getting these 'feelings' and they make me react before I know what's happening. I've been so preoccupied with trying to figure them out that I wasn't paying attention. I'll try to fight you properly now."

Daisy's face fell. "You mean to tell me you weren't even paying attention to our fight?!"

"I, um... not really..." Phoebe said, feeling embarrassed. "I'm sorry. I'm not trying to humiliate you, sweetheart. I just... I don't know what's going on with me."

Daisy glanced over at the other teenagers. Everyone was looking at her with eyes full of pity, a fact that made her want to crawl in a hole and die.

It was only now that she understood why her dad must have fallen in love with Mom. Phoebe was insanely strong. Daisy had a long way to go before she could match up to her parents!

I was too childish, thinking I could easily best one of King Arthur's strongest warriors. Daisy thought somberly. *My mom is totally kick-ass! I'm gonna try and learn as much as I can from her!*

Daisy had no idea of the truth. She just assumed this was her mother's normal combat power, perhaps amplified by her new bodily strength.

But Jason knew that what was happening to Phoebe was a huge alteration from the future Phoebe he loved. This younger Phoebe had turned into a god of combat after a brief meditation period, making Jason ponder on what the hell the Sphinx's power was really all about. Jason didn't know Bahamut well, and Kar was a bit of a lunkhead, but Blinker was highly intelligent, and she'd never told him about something like this happening to her.

Then again, Blinker hadn't been the Sphinx for long before she lost the power to Zamiel, who then fell to Mephisto's machinations. Perhaps she never got to truly investigate what it was capable of?

While Jason pondered, Phoebe went on the attack! She rushed forward and hefted her sword, slashing horizontally toward Daisy's waist. Daisy grinned, then bent her body, using telekinesis to augment her movements. She was able to perform a low-back-bending dodge that caused Phoebe's sword to slice across the empty air where her chest had been only a moment before.

Daisy spun like a fairy on her toes, zipped to the side and turned to face her mother. Before she could complete a revolution, she felt a light impact on her back.

Daisy's eyes widened. She realized that somehow, Phoebe's sword had struck her back! It didn't hurt at all, and Daisy barely even felt it, but she was perfectly familiar with the

sensations of the 'noodle swords' striking flesh. Jason had demonstrated what the swords felt like for all the teens so they knew they were in no danger when training with them.

Daisy looked at her mother in disbelief. "You hit me?"

"I-I'm sorry!" Phoebe exclaimed, pulling away with a look of worry on her face. "Did I injure you, Daisy? I thought Jason said these swords couldn't hurt a fly!"

Daisy looked at the sword in her mother's hands. Her expression was a mixture of shock and awe, as well as disbelief. "No, you- you didn't hurt me, but... I couldn't even see..."

Daisy failed to get the words out. Her mother was a goddamned monster! With her instructions, Daisy was sure to raise her combat capabilities threefold at the minimum! She wasn't even mad or embarrassed anymore, because one simply couldn't feel embarrassment when outclassed by such an expert. A loss was simply inevitable!

"Again!" Daisy shouted.

Like this, the two women started exchanging a torrent of blows. Daisy yelped again and again as Phoebe's sword lightly struck her rump, her chest, her shoulders, her back, even her throat and face!

Once Phoebe realized her sword couldn't cause Daisy any harm, she took the fight a lot more seriously. Her speed increased, and her movements rapidly became more refined. If Daisy was taking a blow every few seconds before, she began taking a blow every second afterward, and then two blows a second.

Eventually, Daisy dropped to her knees, gasping for breath. She was soaked with sweat from physical exertion, but her eyes were shining with brilliance.

"I- I submit!" Daisy said, raising a palm. "You're incredible, mo- I mean, miss Berthold. I don't stand a chance!"

Phoebe stood stably on the stage, and unlike Daisy, she wasn't breathing heavily at all. She looked like she'd gone for a light jog, at most. Jason and the others noticed this difference, with the teenagers crowing in excitement.

"We've gotta fight now!" Jerome shouted. "Hey lady- I mean, Phoebe! Spar with me! I wanna test my strength against you, right here and now!"

Phoebe hesitated. The young man was quite tall, and his body was physically imposing, but Phoebe wasn't sure which of the two of them was stronger.

"Well, alright..." Phoebe said hesitantly. "I guess that's okay."

"GREAT!" Jerome crowed. "And let's ditch the swords. I know you're strong! Let's match strength!"

"Hold on a second." Jason said, frowning. "The swords are best used for situations like these. Phoebe is still adjusting to her new strength."

"Heh, don't worry, Trueborn. I'll go easy on her." Jerome said, giving Jason a thumbs-up, along with a wink.

"I... that isn't exactly what I meant." Jason grumbled.

"It's fine. I'll fight him." Phoebe said, tossing her sword aside. "Let's try grappling. It's a good match of direct strength."

"Sure, but we'll arm-wrestle first just to compare strength directly." Jerome said.

This was agreeable to both of them. Jason set up a stone table with cushions for both their elbows, and like this, Jerome and Phoebe placed their palms in each other's grasp and looked their opponent in the eye.

Phoebe was smaller than Jerome, and her hand was much tinier than his. Keeping to his word, Jerome didn't go overboard. He took the match seriously, but didn't treat it as a life and death battle.

"Hrrrgh!" Jerome groaned, as the arm-wrestling began.

"Grrrr!" Phoebe growled back.

She tried, she really did. But as the seconds ticked by, Jerome started pulling Phoebe's hand backward, then he eventually pressed the back of her hand flat against the table.

The match was over in only twenty-four seconds. Jerome won handily, and it seemed he still had strength in reserve. From this, Jason and the others could tell Phoebe was not his match physically. It seemed the Sphinx power-up hadn't skyrocketed her strength to the point she was more muscular than Jerome.

"Alright!" Jerome said. "Now... are you still okay with doing some wrestling?"

Phoebe nodded. "If I lose, then I lose. It's fine either way."

"That's a good attitude!" Jerome praised. "It don't matter if you win or lose, just that you always learn from your defeats!"

The two of them stood up and squared off in the arena. Jerome grabbed Phoebe's hands and tried to throw her to the mat, but she pulled backward instead and threw him off-balance. Jerome grunted as he stumbled slightly, then Phoebe swept his legs and sent him to the mat. She tried to get on top of him to pin him down, but Jerome was a full foot taller than her. He rolled and tossed Phoebe aside, laying her out on the ground, then he tried to pin her as well.

However, Phoebe was slippery like a snake. She wormed her way out of his grasp and rolled underneath his huge body, then grabbed his leg and pulled it away, making him land face-down on the mat. Phoebe managed to jump on Jerome's back and wrap an arm around his throat, so he threw himself in reverse and slammed onto his back, pounding Phoebe against her back as well!

"Rrrrgh, shit!" Jerome cursed, as Phoebe stubbornly kept an arm wrapped around his throat. He tried to pry her off, but he couldn't get the leverage he needed. Phoebe wrapped her legs around his waist, then spun him to the side, once again pinning him to the floor.

Ten seconds later, it was over. Phoebe won, but this time she genuinely looked tired. It seemed she was barely able to beat Jerome's raw strength with technique, but if it had been a true life and death battle, it was anyone's guess who would have won.

"Man, shit. *Shit*." Jerome cursed after the battle was over. He rubbed his jaw soothingly, looking Phoebe up and down. "You're strong as hell, girl. I really thought I had a chance at the start."

"You were too brutish." Phoebe said, surprising even herself as she analyzed the battle in her head. "You rely on your superior strength too much. Your technique is poorly developed, and your agility is insufficient. I was able to surpass you by pushing my body to its limits."

She paused before adding, "Still, I could tell you were trying not to hurt me, because if you were, I'd probably have lost. One solid punch and I'd be knocked out cold."

"Punching's against the rules when you grapple someone." Jerome pointed out.

"Yes, but in a theoretical life and death battle, rules don't truly apply." Phoebe said.

"You ain't wrong." Jerome agreed thoughtfully.

After a bit more back and forth, Jason finally intervened.

"Everyone, it's been a long day. I think we should all give Phoebe some space and let her adapt to her improved body." Jason said. "Daisy, why don't you help me take Miss Berthold home?"

Daisy nodded obediently. "Alright, dad."

With this, Jason dismissed everyone but his daughter and Phoebe. They all left, including Nadia, and just like that, the three of them were alone again.

"Well, Phoebe, if I said I was impressed by your strength, I'd be underselling it." Jason said with a smile. "Truly overwhelming. I was right to give you the Sphinx's power. I'll be relying on you in the future, if that's okay with you."

Phoebe nodded solemnly. "I will not let you down. Now that I have this power, I intend to use it responsibly."

"That's good, but first, I'd like to take you in for a medical examination." Jason said. "For your body to grow this strong, this quickly, I want to make sure there aren't any side effects. Are you okay with that?" Jason asked. "We'll also get an accurate measurement of your strength, test your reflexes, and other such things."

Daisy nodded along to her father's words, clearly excited by the thought of simply spending time with both her parents. As for Phoebe, she hesitated...

To Phoebe, she was playing a dangerous game. She didn't want to alert the Wordsmith to the Sphinx's true existence, but she didn't want to lie to him either. And she wouldn't have met the Sphinx if it wasn't for Jason anyway, so she felt she owed him enough to at least do as he asked.

Of course, if Jason asked her to start butchering innocents, Phoebe would immediately turn against him. She really hoped he wasn't hiding an evil side of himself from her. He probably wasn't, but one could never be too certain when it came to the thoughts and desires of others.

"Well, alright." Phoebe eventually said. "But maybe tomorrow? I'm pretty tired after all this exercise."

"Oh, sure!" Jason said. "I thought you still had a lot of energy left. But by all means, sleep for a whole day or two if you want. We've got lots of time here."

Jason started to lead his daughter and Phoebe out of the gymnasium. As they departed, Phoebe looked up at the pitch-black sky with its false sun orbiting the tiny

planet.

"That's true. We do have lots of time, due to the temporal dilation. You said it was 365 to 1, yes? So one day on Earth is a year here?"

Jason blinked. He looked at Phoebe with a strange gaze. "Yeah. I'm... surprised you understand it now. You seemed pretty baffled before."

"Well, that was then, and this is now." Phoebe said with a shrug of her shoulders. "It's merely a little temporal dilation. Heaven has it, and so do lots of other places. It's nothing too special, in the grand scheme of the universe."

"Ah... I suppose that *is* true." Jason mumbled.

Jason continued to walk with Phoebe and Daisy. Daisy started chatting her mother up, subtly trying to learn more about her past in the way an ordinary teenager would, all while reveling in the act of speaking to her mother for real!

But Jason didn't say much. Phoebe's abrupt enlightenment had spooked him.

Was there more going on with her than what he saw on the surface?

Part 767: Leader of Punishment

January 29th, 2021. 6PM Washington DC, 3AM Egypt.

At the base of Mount Sinai, the temperature was a comfortable 60F, or 15C. It was a warm night, despite being late in January, proof of just how warm the land of Egypt was year-round.

In the pitch-blackness of the pre-dawn hours, demons secretly milled around, with many Rumbler demons rapidly tunneling out and reinforcing a network of underground tunnels to hastily construct an underground fortification at their leaders' behest.

At this point, only two Demon Emperors had arrived on scene. They were Belial, leader of the Second Hell of Lust, and Diablo, leader of the Fifth Hell of Calamity. The others were scheduled to arrive much later in the day, after the main fortifications had been built.

Diablo paced back and forth atop the surface level of Saint Catherine's monastery. He grumbled under his breath, while Belial casually leaned against a wall, watching him with a bored expression on her face.

"What's bothering you now?" Belial asked casually. "You're always so antsy."

"Of course I'm 'antsy'." Diablo grumbled, casting her a quick glance. "We're not ready at all. This offensive wasn't supposed to happen for several more decades! And now we're trying to rush a million demons into position to assault Sinai in only a day or two?? Satan must have gone insane."

"He's not insane." Belial retorted. "We have no choice but to act now. We presumed the humans would never again have access to a Trueborn Hero, but now they have *two*. The situation is unprecedented."

"Obviously! But attacking *Heaven* of all places?!" Diablo snapped at her, finally pausing his pacing to meet Belial's gaze directly. "We haven't been able to scout them! We don't know how many Lazarites they have, and the number of Titans is a mystery as well. We don't know what defenses they've erected, we don't know if they've secretly brought any human weapons or vehicles into Heaven... we just don't know anything at all!"

He continued. "Even getting a single operative into Heaven requires a colossal amount of time and effort, and the few we've implanted are not able to easily pass their intel to us. We've also lost most of our agents who did manage to get inside due to them getting caught by Camael, the old bitch. This is a disaster waiting to happen!"

"Obviously." Belial said, glancing surreptitiously around, as if worried someone might overhear their conversation. "But we have no choice. We must act. Every day that passes, the humans will grow a little stronger as they consolidate around their two new Heroes."

"Ever since Harold Whittaker died, the humans lost any chance of unifying under a Hero." Belial added. "They became more and more fractured and divided, allowing us to manipulate and deceive them into fighting one another. But if things continue on this new path, we might face a unified humanity, unified angelkind, and even worse, a deepening of an alliance between the two. We have to strike now while the two sides are still disorganized."

Diablo squinted at Belial. "You're not usually the type to care about this sort of stuff."

"Neither are you." Belial shot back. "Aren't you usually napping and eating like a slovenly oaf?"

"Can't nap in peace if the humans get together and kill us all." Diablo grumbled, turning away. "But point taken."

"Yeah, and I only care because Satan does." Belial said. "So, in the meantime, help me whip these grunts into shape. The speed of construction is slowing down, and Satan wants this done by the end of today."

"Yeah, yeah." Diablo said, before stretching, popping his back, and sauntering off to yell at the lowest demon slaves in earshot.

After Diablo left, Belial stood on the spot for a short while, tapping her foot. There was a look of worry on her face.

Our people have low morale and little willpower. Their battle lust is at an all-time low. They have no desire to fight in this war. Surely, Satan has prepared for that?

She chewed on her thumbnail absentmindedly. *The demons have grown more and more slovenly as time has passed. They spend more time sneaking into human 'movies' and consuming human content than they do thinking about how we will someday defeat*

the humans. Now Satan wants to launch a sudden assault on Heaven? Diablo's right. This will be a disaster. Millions, even billions of demons will surely die.

Belial was a relatively compassionate demoness, but even she didn't have it in her heart to care about a million faceless grunts she'd never seen or met. The Broodmothers would spawn more in the future, and more after them, and even more still far beyond those.

Though she didn't give much of a damn about a million demon deaths in the abstract, she worried about Satan and his ambitions. She was practically joined at the hip with her husband. He was her entire world, and whatever his worries were, she shared his burdens equally.

Satan had never stopped dreaming of a day when demons could fully control the Earth. The ancient hatred of the angels had sunk into his bones. He would never forgive them, never consider reconciliation, and never give up the fight.

Since Satan was functionally immortal in all ways that mattered, this meant his hatred would always be demonkind's burden to bear. As such, Belial had to consider him when thinking about the impacts of his future plans and strategies.

"Shit." Belial cursed. "We might need... *his* help."

Belial rubbed her face, feeling slightly depressed.

"Satan's going to make me do it, isn't he? I'm always the one who has to talk to *him*. That absolute lunatic. Why did we ever put him in charge of the Hell of Punishment? He's not right in the head."

The demon she was thinking of was none other than the current head of the Fourth Hell of Punishment. In the future, this leader would come to be Emperor Auger. But at this point in time, it was a different demon entirely, one who had been put in place due to his capabilities, if not his proper capacity for leadership.

In many ways, he was one of the strongest demons alive. But his *personality* on the other hand... nobody liked him, and everyone found him to be insanely irritating. If he didn't have the power needed for the position, he'd have been thrown out a long time ago.

Belial's momentary depression deepened. She felt as if she had aged a year in a minute, thinking of needing to talk to *that bastard*.

"He's *so* annoying." She mumbled. "I just know he's going to stare at my tits the whole time, too."

Belial glanced in the direction of Mount Sinai. At this moment, it was shrouded in an illusory formation that made it appear completely ordinary to anyone looking upon it from afar, even a modern news helicopter.

But Belial knew. Hidden within that formation were hundreds of Pureblooded Angels and thousands of Lazarites, all flying in the air or hidden in various outcroppings, waiting for the demons to launch a sneak attack at night.

Angels had night vision only slightly worse than demons, but far superior to humans. The Lazarites could summon bows that shot magical arrows capable of piercing through human tanks from a kilometer away.

The demons were going to launch a hastily thrown-together assault on Sinai soon. They would need all the help they could get... even if that meant getting someone like *him* to help. Belial wanted to die of embarrassment, just imagining talking to him.

But, well, the Fourth Hell of Punishment was situated in Central Europe, near the border of Germany, Poland, and Czechia. Since Belial was 'nearby', she might as well go and pay that bastard a visit. If she could secure his help now, she would surely make Satan's upcoming war proceed much more smoothly.

Belial looked up into the pitch-black night sky. The sun was still a couple hours away from creeping across the horizon. It was a good cover for her next move.

"Might as well be proactive. Than Satan will praise me." Belial muttered, smiling as she thought of her husband.

She spoke to a Warper nearby and transferred to a Warper Relay in Germany, close by her ultimate destination of the Fourth Hell's base. This saved her nearly 1800 miles of travel distance, and cut down the next part of her trip travel time substantially.

Belial stepped out into the open air on a quiet countryside, still late at night, and gritted her teeth. She tapped into her magical powers, then transformed into her True Succubus form, which covered her body in gray-colored dermal armor, and also caused her to sprout large bat-like wings. Her hands turned into claws, and her eyes became a deep yellow color, with predatory vertical slit-pupils that enhanced her distance vision,

allowing her to spot things from even further away than her baseline demonic physiology already allowed.

The entire process took only thirty seconds. After she finished, Belial launched herself into the air and started flying at high speeds, much faster than if she were to run on foot.

Belial's top running speed was around 100 MPH (160 KPH). This was indeed extremely fast, especially as she could easily jump over obstacles and bypass barriers that would stop a human sportscar from moving that quickly in a straight line.

But even that speed was nothing compared to her flight speed in True Succubus form. If she flew in a straight line and focused entirely on acceleration with no obstacles to slow her down, her top speed ended up breaking past 350 MPH (563 KPH), which was actually not nearly as fast as most human flying machines, but her speed could further increase if she lucked out with a strong tailwind behind her.

And so, like this, Belial traveled a hundred miles in only fifteen minutes, surging across the sky while keeping an eye out for human weapons that might spot and fire at her. It was always risky, traveling out in the open air like this. Humans might not 'know' about the existence of demons, but the true rulers of humanity had long put in place tens of thousands of micro-contingencies to keep an eye on demonic movements.

If the battle at Sinai wasn't the most important thing she'd had to do in the last several hundred years, Belial would never have taken a risk like this. But for now, she didn't have a choice.

She flew through the skies and arrived at a small forest grove, seemingly ordinary, located at the boundary of three different European countries. One might expect there to be walls or other such clearly outlined borders here, but the local governments didn't have any worries about illegal aliens crossing here of all places, so they didn't bother.

As for the location of the Hell of Punishment's home base, like with all the other Hells, this was a closely guarded secret. Demons rarely traveled here directly, typically moving around the Earth via Warpers and underground tunnels.

Belial dove toward the ground. She de-transformed in midair, reverting to her ordinary succubus form, and fell into the treeline with practiced movements. Instead of crashing into the trees like a cannonball, she stretched out her right arm before her, pierced the tree canopy, and grabbed onto a large branch. She easily slowed her

momentum down and gently fell into the underbrush, sliding down the trees and hopping from trunk to trunk until she lightly struck the forest floor.

As dark as it was at night, it was even darker inside the forest. Luckily, Belial's eyes were at the level of a Demon Emperor, so it was as easy to see for her as it would be for a human when the sun was dipping below the horizon. She wasn't able to see perfectly, but she could easily make out her surroundings.

Belial glanced around to get her bearings. She headed east, then stopped at one particular tree which had a unique look to it. It seemed as if a giant Elm had slowly bent over from the weight of its canopy over the years and eventually rested its 'head' against the ground, forming an arch one could walk through.

Belial strode under the arched tree, crossed her arms, and stood in place.

After five minutes, a female voice spoke. "Belial? What are you doing here?"

Belial turned to the side. She saw a beautiful demoness with long green hair approaching her, a woman who wore clothing made of leaves and vines, seductive, yet innocent in an untouched sort of way. She wore a crown of flowers, ones she re-grew daily with her abilities, always changing her fashion along with her whims. A cute little tail swung around behind her, flicking from side to side with catlike movements.

"Nymph." Belial said cordially. "I'm here to see... *him*."

"You are?" Demon Emperor Nymph asked. "But I thought you hated the big man?"

"My distaste has nothing to do with it." Belial said blandly. "There's a war coming, and soon. We need all the strength we can get, and your boss has been notably absent from Satan's summons."

"Well, you know us. We don't like to involve ourselves unless it's important..." Nymph said hesitantly.

"Tell it to someone who cares." Belial snarked. "Take me to him. I don't have time to waste."

"Aaalrighty then..." Nymph said, dragging out her words as if to allow Belial a chance to change her mind.

Sadly for Nymph, Belial did not. Nymph sighed.

"Oh, he's going to be so *grumpy* now." Nymph pouted.

Nymph waved her hand. A random patch of grass nearby split apart, revealing that the underbrush had been hiding a stairway down into the depths of the Earth. She led the way, striding down those stairs, while Belial followed behind.

"I can't believe you choose to stay here." Belial grumbled, as she walked behind Nymph, staring at the green-haired Demon Emperor's back. "Your boss is such a creep."

"He's a little ostentatious, but not such a bad guy once you get to know him. You simply have to watch out for his 'bad' days." Nymph explained.

"Sounds like something an abuse victim would say." Belial spat.

"He's not abusive at all, you just never let yourself get to know him." Nymph shot back, turning her head to glare at Belial.

The two women fell silent. Nymph led her hundreds of feet into the bowels of the Earth, where they arrived inside a gigantic underground space absolutely teeming with life. Demons were not the overwhelming majority of creatures living in the Fourth Hell of Punishment, but were matched head-for-head by goblins and minotaurs. The goblins had one primary job, and that was to dig out the bowels of the Earth, constantly enlarging the underground space. The minotaurs were the guards, always on the lookout for intruders.

There were demons present. Many of them, millions, all spread out in luxurious underground areas with high temperatures that would kill a human if they stayed down here for an hour or so. The sweltering heat didn't affect the demons, goblins, or minotaurs much. They were all quite fine with the heat, and most of them barely even felt it.

What made the Hell of Punishment stand out from the other Hells, architecturally, was its usage of flowers, plants, leaves, and other greenery. Emperor Nymph loved plants, and her handiwork could be seen everywhere. Vines coated the ceiling, supporting it and preventing cave-ins while also forming wooden candelabras that provided constant illumination.

There were pillars that were clearly trees growing underground, supporting the roof in addition to the vines. These tree-pillars were often carved and etched with various drawings by demon artisans.

The Hell of Punishment had an ominous name, but it was actually quite a free-spirited Hell, one filled with demons and monsters who spent most of their time engaging in raucous acts of sex and violence.

If there was one thing that the Hell of Punishment did that made it incompatible with modern human life, it was that it had a frightening number of sadistic demons who loved to inflict torture on other life-forms. Capturing humans from the world above, dragging them into the depths of the Fourth Hell, and tying them up while performing all manner of barbarous acts was by far the thing that most made them a pariah. If the humans ever uncovered the Fourth Hell's exact location, Judgment Day was sure to follow.

In terms of actual villainy, their only competition was the Seventh Hell of Corruption, ruled by Emperor Yama. And *nobody* wanted to interact with that sadistic rapist...

Belial looked around as Nymph led her down toward the heart of the Fourth Hell. Wherever they walked, eyes fell on their bodies. Demons and monsters alike crowed with excitement.

"Yooo, Nymph! Nymph, we're having an orgy in a little bit! Are you in??"

Nymph batted her eyes. "Not right now! Maybe later!"

Belial rolled her eyes. The truth was, Nymph might reside with the Fourth Hell, but she actually originated from the Hell of Lust. She was a succubus, like Belial, but she hated competing for the same pool of 'lovers' as the other succubi, so when she became a Duke, she transferred to the Fourth Hell to better monopolize a bigger pool of people. She had less competition here, and her innocent appearance was simply a facade to make herself more attractive to potential copulation partners.

"Great, see you then! And bring your friend, she's HOT!" The male demon cackled.

"You idiot, that's Belial!" Another demon shouted, slapping his friend over the head. "She'll beat your ass!"

"Great! Hey Belial, pin me down and beat me to a pulp, babyyy!!"

Belial remained stone-faced. In this life, she only loved Satan. No other demon held any place in her heart. She was completely and utterly loyal to him and him alone. She would have sex with other men and women, sure, but only if he ordered her to do so, usually for political reasons.

Belial had zero interest in anyone but her husband. In this regard, she was a weird succubus. She didn't have interest in multiple partners, and even though she'd been with the same man for thousands of years, she was still head over heels crazy for him. She'd do anything he asked, assume any position...

The moment the idiot male demons were out of sight, Belial forgot about them. If she hadn't heard a billion men shout lustful lines at her just like those, she'd certainly heard a million. At this point, they were like drops of rain sliding off a raincoat. They had zero impact on her whatsoever.

Ten minutes later, they arrived at the entrance to an underground garden. Belial rolled her eyes again when she heard the giggles of multiple women mixed with the grunts and groans of just as many men.

Nymph paused after they stepped inside the garden. Whatever was going on up ahead, it was hidden by a giant tree growing in the lightly-illuminated underground space. The tree itself had bioluminescent leaves that glowed with a gentle blue light.

"Do you want to wait?" Nymph asked.

"I'm in a rush. So no." Belial growled.

She stormed forward and rounded the corner to see a pile of male and female demons all intertwined together, moaning sexually while sucking, licking, and fucking each other, performing all sorts of raunchy acts. It wasn't anything she hadn't seen a million times.

"Alright! Fuck time's over!" Belial shouted, projecting her voice loudly enough to startle the pile of writhing red flesh. "I'm here with a message from Satan!"

A single male head turned to look at her. He was a handsome demon with shoulder-length black hair, slanted eyes, and pearly white teeth. He was also completely naked and currently deep inside a demoness Belial didn't recognize.

"Hey hey, I hear you, Beli!" The Male Demon Emperor said. "Gimme thirty minutes and I'll be done! Maybe sooner, if you wanna 'help' me out, eh?"

Belial's fingers suddenly transformed into knives. "How about I cut it off?"

"Ahhh, ahaha! I was just kidding, girl!" The boss of the Fourth Hell said, quickly pulling out and jumping up. He was a sorry sight, messy and unkempt, covered in all sorts of unmentionable juices and smells. "Let's not act hastily!"

Belial maintained her knife hands. "You ignored Satan's summons. Seems you've been getting a bit big for your britches."

"I was just waiting for him to ask me nicely, that's all!" The Emperor said, his two vampire fangs poking out of his mouth as he grinned sheepishly. "Now that you're here, that's good enough for me!"

The Demon Emperor was a thin man, lean and muscled, and he stood seven feet tell, half a foot taller than Belial herself. Even so, she felt a lot more fearsome, especially given that in terms of physical strength, she vastly outclassed him.

But what made the leader of the Fourth Hell so fearsome wasn't his physical body. Rather, it was his particular set of powers.

"Clean yourself up." Belial said. "You smell disgusting."

"Can't just interrupt a fella mid-boink and expect him to smell like roses." The Fourth Hell's leader retorted.

Belial sighed. She found his voice painfully annoying, but that was because of her deep devotion to Satan. It just so happened that his voice had a hypnotic effect on other women, making some of them fall deeply in love with him, and others became at least a little enamored, seeing him as extremely cute, sexy, or otherwise. The power of his voice was truly fearsome.

"Right. Well, whatever." Belial said, finally lowering her fingers and reverting them back to normal. "Satan moved up the schedule. We're going to be attacking Mount Sinai, and we need your help."

"Little old me?" He asked, touching his lip innocently.

"That's right. And you don't have the right to refuse, *Emperor Morbius*." Belial spat. "Don't think just because you rule one of the Seven Hells that you don't need to follow Satan's commands."

"Yes, yes, I know." Morbius said, as he strode over to a towel rack and started wiping his nude body clean. "Satan wants to swing his demonhood around and start a war, and *I* have to go out there and fight on the frontlines of his battlefield."

Morbius sighed as he looked up at the ceiling.

"Took the bastard long enough to finally make a move..."

Part 768: Unbreakable Vow

January 29th, 2021. 6PM Washington DC, 3AM Fourth Hell of Punishment.

Less than fifteen minutes passed before Emperor Morbius cleaned himself up and strode out to meet Belial again. He wore a bathrobe, allowing his unkempt hair to dangle down to his neck. Belial found his face to be quite thin, wiry, and 'pointy'. Not attractive by any means, yet Morbius was somehow a demon of great influence with the opposite sex, creating a whole cult of devotees who seemed to hang on his every word.

Belial had no idea how that happened, even if Demon Emperors in general were often flocked to because of their strength. Clearly, there was something magnetic about Morbius, but it simply didn't affect her at all.

"Hah, I apologize for the delay, Belial." Morbius laughed awkwardly, gesturing vaguely toward what could barely be called an 'outfit' he had donned. A black bathrobe exemplified his laziness perfectly. "Now that I'm decent, tell me what Satan needs. I'm all ears."

Belial rolled her eyes. She did that a lot whenever she was in Morbius's presence. His voice had an overly breathy tone to it, as if he were putting on a Shakespearean play for whoever he was speaking to. It made him sound melodramatic, but any attempt to point this out only resulted in looks of dismay or gasps of disbelief, as if he couldn't *possibly* understand what nonsense she was going on and on about.

"We're going to be attacking Heaven." Belial repeated, as she closed her eyes and raised a hand to massage the headache she was developing out of her forehead. "Satan wants to kill one or more of the Archangels, and as many Titan Kings as possible."

"Ambitious." Morbius said dismissively, his voice drifting into her ears like a termite burrowing into a dead tree. "I can understand his desire to eliminate our greatest enemy, but this is all so *sudden*. Why now? Weren't we going to wait a few decades to scout out the inner picture of Heaven? We have no idea what we're going up against."

"We have no choice." Belial grumbled, pressing her fingers harder against her forehead. "There are two Trueborn Heroes now. This is unprecedented. One of the Heroes is apparently a time traveler. He fought Emperor Ose and beat her handily. He has the ability to rewind time an infinite number of times, meaning it's very likely he already

knows all our plans and has made contingencies for them. We don't know if he knows about our future assault on Heaven, the assault tomorrow, or an infinite number of variants we tried before and failed or possibly succeeded. We're at a complete loss when it comes to information warfare."

Have you tried contacting Yama?" Morbius suggested. "His Shades might be able to slip inside Heaven."

Belial opened her eyes. She did her best to ignore the fact that Morbius's eyes were, as always fixated on her chest.

"Heaven's Light pervades all corners of the realm." Belial said, carefully crossing her arms over her chest to obstruct his view. "Shades who enter Heaven will simply die. This is also why Yama won't be any help with the upcoming battle, unless we can find a way to diminish Heaven's Light dramatically."

Belial paused. She remembered an important fact at that moment. During the first War in Heaven, the demons did successfully manage to drastically dim Heaven's Light at the climax of the final battle. This was due to the power of the Archdemon... but nobody knew exactly how Diablo did it, including the man himself.

In the end, if the demons didn't know how to replicate the feat, and they had no way to sneak into Heaven to try and experiment, then it didn't really matter.

"We will need your power." Belial concluded. "Along with that of the other Emperors. Yama might not be of any use inside Heaven, but he will serve us well on the outside, where darkness and shadows reside. He can prevent unwanted entities from intruding."

"Fine, I'll do what I must then." Morbius said. "The Hell of Punishment will join this idiotic battle. You do understand this could result in a total wash for us, though? All the soft power we've built up over millennia will crumble if we suffer a catastrophic loss. Our threat will greatly diminish in the eyes of the humans."

Morbius might be a creep, but he wasn't an idiot. Belial had to acknowledge his words with a nod, even if she didn't want them to be true.

"Satan is aware, as am I and all the others. But we don't have a choice." Belial grumbled. "Taking out at least one Archangel will pay dividends in the future. Eliminating two or more could collapse the strength of one of our three enemy factions."

It was at this moment Morbius said something Belial never would have expected from the likes of him. "Has Satan considered the diplomatic option?"

"Excuse me?" Belial said, frowning.

"Satan seems to be operating under the assumption co-existence with the other species is impossible." Morbius said, fanning out his fingernails to look at them while he spoke. "I wasn't there during the original War in Heaven, so I don't really know what all went down. But surely even he has to understand how badly the deck is stacked against us?"

Morbius continued. "Right now, it's Demons and Monsters against Humans, Angels, and Titans. The humans have developed dramatically over the last two hundred years. Their 'machines' are already quite scary, and they seem to be getting more and more effective at killing us as time goes on. Your operating assumption that we are soon going to be 'screwed' now that the humans have two Trueborn feels flawed from the outset. From where I'm sitting, it seems as though we were already screwed just based on the humans' development speed. With or without a Hero, I don't think they're going to lose this war."

Belial was stunned. For once, Morbius wasn't even looking at her, or her tits. He was simply examining his nails, pulling that thought out of what she assumed was the black hole known as his brain.

"H-human machines aren't *that* strong." Belial protested. "Even I can take down one of their flying machines with ease."

Morbius met her eyes. His expression was serious, for once. "Of course you can. You're an *Emperor*. Any Emperor can stand up to one of their war machines; that's nothing worth bragging about. But what if ten of them surrounded you? A hundred? A thousand? What if they were determined, truly determined, to kill or capture you? What if they started deliberately tracking and hunting you? They can just keep shitting those metal behemoths out, and any ordinary human can control them. Could you withstand that level of force?"

The Fourth Emperor paused deliberately. "Could a Duke? A Baron? Let alone anyone weaker than them? And that's only talking about the machines we see and know about now. What about the ones covertly being developed behind closed doors? What if the Trueborn didn't show up and we continued on the path of attacking Heaven in a few

decades? Don't you think the human weapons would become even more frightening compared to the ones we've seen up to now?"

Belial blinked. She hadn't given this matter much thought. She was caught off-guard by Morbius's line of questioning. Naturally though, she assumed the brilliant Satan had thought of these matters. *Surely* he had factored those questions into his logic and train of thinking.

"Well," Morbius said, after several long seconds of silence from his verbal-opponent, "it's not too late to change Satan's mind. I think we were screwed from the start. Diplomacy could keep our people alive and allow us to reap the rewards of symbiotically living alongside the humans. I don't know about you, but I'm quite tired of holing up underground, rarely getting to experience the warmth of the sun. It turns my skin a pale pink."

"Satan is also tired of living in the darkness." Belial finally said, recovering from her shock though she was still flustered. "That's why we need to claim the Earth for ourselves."

"It's not going to go well for us." Morbius observed. "I can see the writing on the walls. So can the other Emperors. They won't say anything, because everyone's afraid of pissing Satan off. We all know he owns our asses. The difference between me and them is that I'm more attached to enjoying my good life than I'm afraid of pissing Satan off. Though, yeah, I am still afraid of pissing him off. Rest assured, I'll follow orders and attack Heaven, but I just think this is an idiotic move that will likely cost us infinitely more than it gains."

Belial hardened her gaze. "Satan has led us to our current prosperity. I won't tell him what you've said, but you'd do well to keep your mouth shut in the future. He thinks much further ahead than even you know."

"You're probably right, but even the most brilliant leaders have blind spots." Morbius retorted. "Satan's blind spot is his obvious hatred for the angels. His thirst for revenge is going to cost him, and the rest of us, everything."

"We'll see." Belial said, concluding the conversation.

She dismissed herself after getting one last assurance from Morbius that he would fight at the battle of Sinai in one day's time. Then, she left the Fourth Hell, feeling a little worse for wear.

What does an idiot like Morbius know? Belial thought after she stepped back out into the night-time darkness. It was 4 AM now, and she'd spent about 45 minutes inside the Fourth Hell. *Satan's true plan has nothing to do with killing the Archangels. That's just a cover to deceive the others and obfuscate his true intentions. Satan's so-called 'thirst' for vengeance has also dulled over time. His hatred for the angels is almost entirely a hatred for Raphael, not every other Archangel.*

Belial grimaced. *The true point of this invasion is to steal back Valac's Lantern. If we can obtain it, we will seize control of the power of revival and use it to build a new realm for demonkind. Killing Raphael and other leaders in Heaven would be a nice bonus, but pale in comparison to actually obtaining the Lantern.*

Even as Belial had this thought, she shivered, her bones turning cold from fear.

But what if the humans know? What if Cat Mask knows? He must know, right? Surely he witnessed our attempts to start this war in one of the futures he lived through. How much of our plans does he know? Or maybe what we're doing now is completely new to him? Maybe we never even tried this before?

The knowledge that a time-traveler was among their enemies made Belial extremely worried. This news had greatly shaken her resolve, and Satan's as well. It would be one thing if they didn't know, but now that Ose had told them of Cat Mask's capabilities, they were constantly second and third-guessing themselves.

What if cat Mask knew what they were doing?

What if he didn't?

Would he actively work to stop them?

Would he let them do as they pleased?

What if obtaining the Lantern was actually a poison pill for demonkind? Maybe the Lantern itself had been tampered with ahead of time? Maybe Cat Mask had already told Raphael, and the angels knew exactly what the demons were planning!

The possibilities made Belial want to break down and cry. Morbius's words had shaken her resolve even more because the truth was, she completely agreed with him! She thought this war was a terrible idea, but she couldn't bear to tell her husband 'no'. If Satan wanted something, Belial would do anything he asked to help him acquire it. This showed the depths of her love and devotion, and the weaknesses in her personality as well.

Even though she felt saddened by this news, she pressed on. Belial transformed into a True Succubus once again, leaped into the sky, and flew low to the ground, moving quickly to return to the Warper Hub in Germany.

Before long, she would be back in Sinai, readying up for the next phase of Satan's plan...

At the same time, in Heaven.

While the demons were making their moves, so too were the angels. Raphael was aware the demons had assaulted Saint Catherine's Monastery and killed many of the humans there. Luckily, he knew that at least some of the humans had managed to escape. That was because the church's leader had activated Catherine's Sigil, which mainly served to alert Heaven to a demonic incursion. It also meant the deacon had opened the secret passageway and escaped through the tunnels.

Odds were good the demons hadn't pursued the humans who escaped. They could do so, of course, but knowing the demons, they simply paid little attention to random nobodies among the human ranks. The demons actually had quite a blind spot to 'ordinary' humans, and mainly put their focus on celebrities and other noteworthy people. This was a glaring weakness in their psychology that prevented them from paying attention to countless obscure engineers and other inventors who silently toiled away from the public eye, making tremendous contributions to human science.

It also allowed ordinary people to go about their daily lives, unmolested by the touch of demonic influence. Whether this would last into the foreseeable future or not was anyone's guess.

Raphael was currently sitting within his residence, a spacious and livable home filled with books he had collected over the eons, written himself, or had commissioned from humans and angels alike. His personal library mainly consisted of his favorite tomes, but he had built a much larger one in a somewhat remote corner of Heaven filled with obscure titles he only browsed occasionally.

The Archangel of Wisdom was, in all meanings, the leader of Heaven. Even so, he did not live an opulent life. His dwelling was larger than that of most other angels, but he had no servants, and he certainly didn't live inside a mansion. His dwelling was surprisingly

humble, a large hollowed-out tree with multiple vertical levels linked by holes in the floor leading upward. As an angel, he could fly upward and did not need staircases.

Raphael sat before a window overlooking the interior of Heaven. His giant tree was grown atop a small hill, not quite a mountain, which gave him a wide view of all the other living spaces within Heaven, the distant forests, and at the edge of his vision, even the gate leading to Sinai itself.

His vision was keen, but even Raphael could not make out much in the way of those going in and out of Heaven's Gate. With a demonic attack arriving in the near future, there were many angels, mostly Lazarites, coming and going.

Raphael's home was not a simple structure made of brick and mortar. It was grown and hand-crafted by Uzziel herself for her brother. The colors inside were darker, more muted than the brightness of the world outside.

But Raphael's home was unique in this regard. He might live inside a hollowed-out tree, but the Lazarites within Heaven did not.

Heaven did not look the way it did during the Ancient Era. Lazarites were humans who had died. As such, when they arrived in Heaven, they brought human knowledge, human customs, and human *engineering* along with them. Countless Lazarites who had been reborn were artisans, craftsman, construction workers, and others of that sort. In recent decades, more humans had been born and died than ever in the past, and these new humans had caused the shape of Heaven to change dramatically.

Raphael strictly forbade the use of electricity. He felt it was too alien for the likes of Heaven, but if he had allowed it, he might have been able to obtain a sizable fraction of the human war machine for himself. Alas, since he forbade it, the humans instead brought along with them their construction methods, building high-rise apartment buildings illuminated by Heaven's Light, rather than bulbs running on electrical power.

Heaven had a moderate climate year-round. Angels did not need to consume food, so Lazarites didn't need to farm like they would have if they were still alive on Earth. That didn't stop many Lazarites from alleviating their boredom by growing lavish gardens over time, or building fancier and more ornate statues, structures, and so on.

Lazarites were intended to be instruments of war Raphael could deploy to battle against the demons, but the truth was, especially in the last few hundred years, battles against the demons rarely rose to a level higher than a moderate city-level skirmish. Most

Lazarites only trained their battle techniques and powers when ordered to do so, and otherwise lived as if they were still humans.

The city that sprawled out below Raphael's house was ugly and unseemly. He hated it. It was made of metal and concrete, not like the old Heaven that had existed before Satan's explosion during the Ancient Era. That Heaven had truly felt like home to the Pureblooded angels, while the one they lived in now felt more like a lesser imitation of the human world outside.

Raphael grumbled to himself. He felt stuck, in a way. Trapped in a quagmire. Lately, he felt as if he'd been following the rhythm of his enemies, allowing a new status quo to slowly form. Now, it was the demons who were setting a new rhythm. He was forced to react to news of their imminent assault and begin preparing for it.

While Raphael stared at the city of Lazarites below his home, a knock at the door made him turn his head to look. He realized he'd been so preoccupied with his thoughts that he had failed to sense a familiar aura approaching.

"Come in, child." Raphael said, smiling warmly. He remained seated, watching at the door opened to reveal a white-haired woman with a halo above her head, the telltale sign she was a Lazarite and not a pureblood. She wore a helmet that covered her face, but took it off when she entered.

Catherine walked inside Raphael's home with the same casual ease she always had, ever since she was a little girl and had arrived in Heaven. She treated Raphael as her parent, because he had always been good to her and lavished care and affection onto her shoulders.

Catherine closed the door. She smiled at Raphael and bowed slightly.

"Father, I've returned." Catherine said.

"Words reached my ears that thou didst vanish after the battle against Lucifer." Raphael said, his heart lightening, ever so slightly. He stood up and walked over to Catherine, giving her a warm and gentle hug. Then he held her arms and looked into her eyes. "Art thou quite alright, my dear? Thou appeareth none the worse for wear."

"I'm sorry, Father." Catherine said, blushing slightly. "I made you worry over nothing. When Lucifer showed up, I fled and had to hide for a while. But I escaped and made my way back here."

Raphael blinked. Was it just his imagination, or did her eyes shift away when she spoke? It felt a little 'off' to him, an ancient entity who had interacted with billions of other beings over his long and storied life.

She was... lying?

Raphael wasn't entirely certain, but he didn't press the matter.

He simply pulled his arms away before touching her cheek lovingly. "That thou still live is my greatest joy. As soon as I heard of thy survival, I called for thee. Since thou art of sound body and mind, come and sit at my table. I have something I must discuss with thee."

Catherine nodded. Her expression turned solemn. Raphael seemed to have a lot on his mind. He was much more serious than usual.

Raphael took a seat at the table next to the window, while Catherine sat across from him. Raphael waved his hand, and two pocelain cups appeared, along with a porcelain pot with heated tea. He picked up and poured the chamomile tea for himself and Catherine, then slid a cup over to her side.

This was a simple ritual the two of them had done a thousand times. Catherine accepted the tea with a nod, then took a sip almost in unison with Raphael, as if their minds were synchronized.

Several seconds of silence followed. Catherine waited, not speaking. She was waiting to hear what was on Raphael's mind.

"War is coming." Raphael stated, causing Catherine to nod along to his words. This much was obvious to anyone. "In these trying times, I must dig up every scrap of battle strength our people mayeth be able to use in the coming fight. Every bit of added strength shalt increase our chances of victory, even if only by a little."

"Of course." Catherine agreed between sips of tea. "And my role?"

"Thou art going to play a part most essential." Raphael said seriously. "Child, thy potential is unlimited. Among the Lazarites, thou art a one-in-a-billion prodigy. I intendeth to place a good deal of focus upon thy future exploits."

Catherine's eyes flickered. Raphael noticed this, and while his facial expression didn't change, a small internal alarm in the back of his head started to tingle. Catherine seemed a little 'off' today, in ways he found indescribable. He immediately deduced more had

happened to her than she let on, but he kept quiet, waiting to see if she would speak of the matter herself.

"Regarding thy sister..." Raphael said slowly, watching Catherine's face as he spoke. ""Tis time for thee to inherit her legacy. Thou art now strong enough of mind and body to wield the power of the D'Arc bloodline."

Catherine's heart jumped. "You... you mean...?"

""Tis not here." Raphael said solemnly. "Joan was a human Hero. Her power was special, even among her fellow Trueborn. She was a religious woman who placed piety the highest among all virtues and drew her power from it. As such, 'twas not appropriate to allow her blade to rest in Heaven."

A long moment of silence followed.

"The Sword From Heaven now resides within Saint Catherine's Monastery." Raphael said, enunciating every syllable deliberately to allow his words to weigh on Catherine's mind. "Thy sister's blade is now in a place surrounded by demons. If thou wisheth to finally take up her legacy, thou must first reclaim it from the demons."

"They've taken my sister's sword?!" Catherine asked, the blood draining from her face.

"Nay." Raphael answered with a shake of his head. "The demons know not the treasure contained within the Monastery. In fact, only I knew of its location. I told neither Camael nor the others. The Sword From Heaven is an artifact on par with the legendary Excalibur. Its power is beyond imagination."

Raphael cleared his throat. "Verily, I am unable to control any artifact once a Trueborn's soul has taken up residence inside. The same is true of the demons, even more so due to their weakness against the divine energy contained within such a blade. The Emperors hath no idea where I've hidden the blade, and even if they dids't, they woulds't not dare touch it."

Catherine relaxed a little. When it came to her sister, she always seemed to lose her sense of reason at least a little. She was still deeply emotionally bonded to the only remaining member of her Earthborn-family, even if that was only in concept. She hadn't actually spoken to Joan since either of their deaths, and this was a fact that had haunted her for centuries.

Naturally, Raphael noticed all the micro-movements on Catherine's face. It was a deliberate tactic he had used over the years, mentioning Joan every so often, as casually as possible, to keep her at the surface of Catherine's mind. Dangling Joan in front of Catherine had always helped keep her in line, and turned her into a very obedient girl who followed her Father's orders.

However, there was that new problem... why did it suddenly seem as though Catherine were keeping something from Raphael? His uncertainty increased more and more the longer he spoke to her.

Raphael cleared his throat. "I shalt assemble a small fighting force. There appear to be two Emperors inside the Monastery. Diablo and Belial. Before other Emperors arrive, I wish for thee to travel there, locate and acquire the Sword From Heaven, and escape the demons before they know what has transpired. With this blade in hand, thy fighting power shalt rise exponentially. Thou shalt truly become the Mightiest Lazarite."

Catherine's expression shifted to one of determination. She immediately nodded. "Yes, of course, Father. But you don't need to send anyone else. I alone am enough."

Raphael's eyebrows jumped. "Absolutely not! If thou wadeth into the waters of thy enemies alone, thou shalt drown. Powerful though thou mayeth be, thou art no match for a Demon Emperor, let alone two of them. To say nothing of the Dukes lurking in the shadows."

Catherine smiled, and that smile had the hints of a smirk. "Oh, you haven't heard, Father? I killed two Demon Dukes today."

Raphael's eyebrows jumped again. "Two?! Impossible! Who were they?"

"The Battle Brothers." Catherine said, before pausing. "I also killed Hamir, the Baron of Frost."

Raphael's jaw slackened. He looked at Catherine with fresh eyes, then sighed and bowed his head. "Thou hath grown, child. I apologize, for I did not notice thy growth had reached such a level."

After chuckling and shaking his head at his ignorance, Raphael raised his gaze once more.

"Even so, Demon Dukes and Emperors art different beasts entirely. It mayeth be possible for thee to slay an Emperor, but thou art underselling the power of our

adversaries. I shalt not be at ease sending thee into the viper's den alone."

"I'm not going to fight my way in." Catherine said, firming her resolve. "I will sneak inside and take the blade before anyone knows what happened. Having others beside me will only slow me down."

Raphael appeared uncertain. "This is a great risk thou art considering, child. I woulds't feel more at ease sending thee in with backup."

"I don't need backup." Catherine said, her tone firmer than before. "I will accomplish this task by myself."

She surprised Raphael, because this was the first time she'd ever spoken so decisively to him. Catherine had always been a woman with a stalwart heart, but in front of her Father, she was a meek mannered girl who did as she was told.

What had caused her to change so dramatically seemingly overnight?

Raphael pondered that question, but he couldn't seem to deduce an answer...

"...Very well, then allow this old man to offer an alternative. I shalt draw the demon's eyes with a feint. I'll send a thousand Lazarites to harass the demons from afar, using ranged weapons. They will rain arrows from above, drawing attention away from the Cathedral. In this way, thou shalt have an easier time sneaking inside."

Catherine opened her mouth. She started to argue with Raphael, but when the old man frowned, she lost her nerve. After a moment, Catherine lowered her eyes, sighed, and nodded.

"Yes, Father. A feint will suffice. It will help me slip inside, unseen."

Raphael's frown didn't disappear. He did not look reassured by her agreement.

"Catherine. Coulds't it be that thou hath grown tired of living? Has suicide begun to play upon the edges of thy mind?" Raphael questioned. "Foolish bravado, perhaps? Might it be that thou actually wisheth to battle against a Demon Emperor? Perhaps in an attempt to prove thy capabilities? Dost thou thinketh thyself unworthy of thy sister's lineage, and this is thy attempt to rectify that shortcoming?"

Catherine's jaw dropped. "Father, what are you talking about? I'm not suicidal, and this has nothing to do with any of that! You're talking nonsense!"

"Then why?" Raphael asked. "Give me an answer, child. Why doth thee insist on fighting alone? Mighty thou mayest be, but thou art not capable of winning against a Demon Emperor."

"S-says who?!" Catherine exclaimed, before slamming the side of her clenched fist against the table. "You don't know that!"

Raphael realized Catherine's outburst was way out of the ordinary. She was acting a lot more impulsively than usual, keeping secrets from him, and now she was even openly talking back? Where did she find the nerve?

"Thou now claimeth thou coulds't combat an Emperor?" Raphael asked, wryly chuckling. "I dare not deny thy talent, but those ancient monsters woulds't leave thee laying on thy back, broken and humiliated. If thou dids't win, t'would be due to a one-in-a-million lucky chance!"

"You're still looking at me as a little girl, incapable of fighting real battles and winning wars." Catherine said, her expression turning frosty. "Father, I am a 600 year old woman! It might be nothing compared to you, but compared to any living human, I am twenty times more ancient than any of their combat veterans. I was trained by the Archangels! I am a human who has gained wings and powers beyond imagination. I am more than capable of taking down powerful threats, but only if given the opportunity!"

Each of Catherine's words were decisive and pointed. Her cold expression was not filled with anger, but instead, confidence and a burning desire to prove herself to the man she called Father. It was as if she knew for a fact she could kill a Demon Emperor, despite never having done so before.

"Dids't thou succeed against Lucifer?" Raphael asked pointedly, his tone much calmer than hers.

Catherine paused.

"...No." She admitted. "I lost. But next time, I will crush her with ease."

Raphael fell silent. He looked at Catherine, then his eyes lowered to the table. He stared at it for a good long while.

"So that's why." Raphael said quietly.

"Huh? *What's* why?" Catherine asked, confused by the change in his tone.

"Thou hath been acting very differently since thou returneth." Raphael said quietly, raising his eyes to meet her gaze. "Verily, it maketh sense now. Lucifer... she must have struck thy mind and done something to thy thoughts."

"Huh??" Catherine grunted in bewilderment. "What does Lucifer have to do with anything we've discussed?"

"Lucifer's third eye is a frightening weapon." Raphael said, his tone soft. "During the War in Heaven, she unleashed it for the first time. Its effects were not obvious at first, but we came to uncover its true power later."

Raphael cleared his throat. "On the surface, her third eye can fire a blast of kinetic energy capable of piercing mountains. Frightening indeed, and certainly a mighty attack, but nothing this ancient entity has not seen a thousand of his ancient adversaries achieve in the past."

"The true danger Lucifer poses is not her physical striking power, but the secret psychic power her third eye possesses." Raphael continued. "Long ago, I gave thee tomes to read containing the knowledge we've collected on the powers of all the Demon Emperors. Dost thou recalleth the entry on Lucifer?"

Catherine blinked. She had definitely read the books Raphael was talking about, but she read them when she was less than a hundred years old, and that was five hundred years ago. She hadn't forgotten the information, but it wasn't fresh in her mind.

With the power of her new MindCore, Catherine was able to access her oldest memories and conjure them at will. She quickly did so, and flipped through the entry on Lucifer.

"That's right..." Catherine muttered. "Lucifer has the power to conjure frighteningly realistic illusions within a person's mind. She refers to it as 'Tsukuyomi'."

"Verily, she secretly struck many Purebloods during the War in Heaven." Raphael muttered. "She injured their psyches, tormented them with delusions of pain and suffering, and caused many survivors to kill themselves after the war. And now... now, thou art acting so out of character after interacting with Lucifer. This ancient Archangel has come to see the truth, Catherine!"

Raphael slapped the table. "Thou hath been struck by Lucifer, and art now experiencing delusions of grandeur! Until Uzziel attends to thee and heals the damage

thou hath suffered, I cannot permit thee to leave Heaven!"

Catherine was taken aback. What psychic attack? She had fought Lucifer, yes, but the battle lasted mere seconds, and Cat Mask swooped in to save her. Admittedly, she hadn't mentioned that to Raphael, but doing so would tip him off that the Trueborn were involved, and that might make him start asking other questions...

But now that it came to it, Catherine realized that Raphael had obviously noticed the different way she was acting, and he had come to the most logical conclusion available to him. Surely, Catherine must be suffering from psychological trauma inflicted by Lucifer.

"Father, no..." Catherine started to say, softening her voice. "This is a misunderstanding. Lucifer did not strike me, in fact, my battle against her was only-"

"Enough." Raphael said, raising a palm. "I cannot trust another word thou sayeth, not until Uzziel has examined thee. Clearly, thou art not in thy right state of mind."

The Archangel of Wisdom stood up and gestured to the door, clearly intending to lead Catherine outside. She also stood up, but did not make a move to go with him.

"You're not listening to me, Father." Catherine said, remaining fixed in place. "You're right, I have changed, but not because of Lucifer."

"Thou hath been hiding something from me since the moment of thy arrival." Raphael said, his eyes piercing her visage. "Thou hath never lied to me in all thy years alive. Whatever has rotted thy morality must be stopped before it causes further damage. Come now. We will pay Uzziel a visit."

"You're NOT listening!" Catherine repeated, shouting the words for emphasis. "There is nothing wrong with me, and Lucifer has nothing to do with any of this!"

"Nay?" Raphael asked, unmoved. "Speak then. What art thou hiding from me? Speak the truth now, child."

Raphael stood on the spot, staring at Catherine expectantly. In truth, he'd already given up hope she would be honest with him, but he did feel he owed her at least a chance to speak her piece.

And now, facing Raphael's stare-down, Catherine's soul went cold. She felt her skin starting to turn itchy and clammy as a terrible internal conflict brewed within her.

On the one hand, she was facing down her 'Father', the Archangel of Wisdom, likely the oldest entity in the Milky Way who had lived since the beginning of this Eternity.

On the other hand, she risked disappointing a young man whose face had immediately left a deep impression on her heart, who she had promised not to speak of in front of Raphael.

Jason had not-so-subtly informed her that Raphael's intentions were far from noble, but even so, 600 years of conditioning had made it impossible for Catherine to truly rebel against the man who had taken up the role of a parent in her mind. Even though she had promised not to speak of Jason's existence, his Wordsmithing, or anything else of the sort, now that she had been put on the spot, Catherine found herself lost, confused, unsure of what to do.

She had to tell Raphael something. It had to be as truthful as possible, yet not so truthful that she failed to keep her promise to Jason for less than a day. How shameful would it be for a D'Arc sister to break a vow right after she made it?!

Thus, Catherine was left tongue-tied. Her heart started to race, and the obvious guilt on her face told Raphael everything he needed to know. Clearly, Catherine had been deeply compromised. Her story of 'escaping from the demons' held no water. Perhaps she had been captured, mind-raped, and turned into a double-agent. Perhaps she was their new woman on the inside, a high level figure who would assist them in the coming battle, turning traitor and landing a devastating blow on one of the Archangels right when they least expected it!

Mind-rape and subversion were completely normal tactics the demons had used a million times. Raphael had seen many Lazarites bought-off or corrupted into becoming double agents over the years, as well as younger and more malleable Titans, and even a handful of purebloods.

It was truly disappointing that Catherine would fall, as they had, and it meant the last 600 years may have been a waste, but Raphael was at least glad he caught on to what had happened before it was too late.

"I, I, I..." Catherine stuttered, starting to feel nauseous as her resolve broke down. "I met with- it wasn't Lucifer... there was... I... I promised not to say... please don't make me say, Father. I made a vow, but I would never harm you, or Heaven, or anyone else."

"I do not believe thy words." Raphael said. "Thou art clearly hiding something from me."

"I-I am!" Catherine snapped, finally speaking the words out loud. "I'm hiding something, because that is my right! Who said I have to tell you everything I think and feel? I am a sentient being, not your puppet! You don't own me, or my thoughts! I am allowed to have secrets, just as I'm sure you have secrets you keep from me!"

Raphael blinked. "Is this truly thy best defense? Naturally, if thou wisheth to hold a few minor things from me, I would say nothing, but when the question of thy morality is on the line, and thou mayeth possibly been corrupted by the demons, I cannot in good conscience allow thee to roam freely until I hath uncovered the scheme behind thy sudden change of heart. There is a war coming, and it may be upon our doorstep in mere hours! This is not the time for me to be dealing with a possible traitor."

"I'm NOT a traitor!" Catherine shrieked. "Stop trying to dissect me, Father! Just stay out of my business, for once in your life!"

"No. I do not think I will." Raphael said.

His movement was sudden, swift, and completely unexpected. Catherine had never realized he was carefully amassing his power until it was too late.

Raphael cleared the distance between them in a single second. He slapped downward at the side of her head and pounded Catherine down into the floor. She had no time to react before he'd already battered her downward and knocked her unconscious.

In a single movement, Raphael subdued Catherine, then wrapped her body with multiple phantasmal chains, in the same way he had done to Satan the Devil in the Ancient Era.

Raphael did not take Catherine to his False Cosmic Realm, though. Instead, her subdued her and turned her body invisible with illusions, then he teleported across Heaven to a meeting hall for the Archangels.

After arriving, Raphael laid down Catherine in the center of the room, still subdued and unconscious. He touched a special ring on his finger, which sent out a signal to the other connected rings worn by his brothers and sisters.

Several minutes later, Camael entered. She did not teleport, but instead strode in through the front doors, looked at Catherine bound on the floor, and frowned.

"This is...?" Camael started to ask, but seeing the look on Raphael's face, she went silent.

Before long, Gabriel arrived, and then Uzziel came last.

Michael was no longer among the living. He had given his life two thousand years earlier to empower the Lazarus Tower.

Samael had gone missing long ago, lost in battle against the demons.

Uriel, too, had fallen during the War in Heaven.

As for Cassiel and Muriel, they had naturally died during the Primordial Era, long before the mindwipes.

Thus, now, among the living Archangels, only Raphael, Gabriel, Camael, and Uzziel remained. Four in total.

At the very least, Raphael now wore Michael's ring, and he could commune with Michael's soul in times of great need. Unfortunately, Michael's soul was weakened dramatically by the existence of the Lazarus Tower, and as such, he spent most of his time in a deep coma-like sleep, only waking up if Raphael injected soul energy to temporarily revive him. Raphael did not do that now.

"Everyone." Raphael said, gesturing to Catherine's unconscious body. "I hath reason to believe Demon Emperor Lucifer mayeth assaulted Catherine's mind. She is acting out of character. She lied to me earlier, something she's never done before, and she is hiding something. Uzziel, thou hath successfully healed some of those corrupted by Lucifer. Please investigate Catherine's condition."

Uzziel frowned worriedly. She quickly fluttered over to Catherine, swallowing her saliva as she audibly gulped.

Catherine was the golden child of Heaven. Few were allowed to know her real name. Her identity as Joan of Arc's sister was a secret kept in great confidence. Even her name was hidden behind the subterfuge of 'Heaven's Daughter'.

If she had truly betrayed Heaven, then this was a catastrophic loss on the eve of a demonic incursion.

Uzziel sent out her healing energy. She carefully wrapped it around Catherine's head, working hard so as to not wake her up.

Gabriel stood on Catherine's left, while Camael stood on her right. The two of them were here purely as muscle in the event Catherine woke up and lashed out at the weakest Archangel, Uzziel. If she was too focused on healing Catherine, she might not sense the

dangr coming, and could be killed before she had a chance to react! This would cause a double tragedy and give the demons a premature win before they had even begun their assault! None of the Archangels wanted to see this happen.

"Strange..." Uzziel said, as she investigated Catherine's brain. "I... I senseth no tampering with her mind. Lucifer's powers always cause noticeable trauma to the victim, but there are no such contusions or lesions present on Catherine's brain."

"The demons art no fools." Raphael said, his tone of voice urgent. "Tis' possible they may have used other tactics. Check her Mind Realm for tampering."

Uzziel nodded. She and the other Archangels were quite familiar with Catherine's Mind Realm. Only Raphael was intimately familiar with it, as he had used his eons of life experience to build her a barebones but functional Mind Realm for the sake of empowering her abilities. Uzziel had helped repair damage to it on many occasions in the past though, so she knew its general structure.

But the moment Uzziel tapped into it, her eyes went wide. She let out a loud cry mixed with a gasp, a sound that communicated disbelief, confusion, and absolute bewilderment.

"Uuuahh??!!" Uzziel shrieked. "Th-th-this, what in Heaven's name- RAPHAEL! Come, look quickly!"

Raphael's heart fell into the soles of his feet. The look on Uzziel's face plunged his mind into the depths of despair. Just what in the Creator's name had those abominable demons done to the prodigy he had invested so much time and energy into raising?! He was terrified to see what they'd done, but Uzziel's tone moved him to act as quickly as possible.

He flickered over to Catherine's body and held his palm above her head. Raphael closed his eyes and focused, diving toward her Mind Realm.

What did he expect to see? Maybe blackness, blood red demonic energy, fire and brimstone, or something else of the sort.

But that wasn't what he saw.

Instead, his vision fell upon a Mind Realm so precisely engineered to perfection, so beautiful and staggering in its size, that he almost lost his mind. Even his own Mind Realm was countless times less extravagant than this bewildering behemoth lurking within his pupil's mind.

Who in the god-damn could have constructed such a thing? It went beyond anything he could have dreamed up or imagined. It was a towering city made in the image of the Titans, each and every building, statue, and structure energized and focused towards the others, forming a powerful glyph-structure that served a purpose he simply couldn't imagine.

It was as if a child were trying to figure out the workings of a computer for the first time by looking at its internal circuits with no guidebook. Even the brilliant Raphael was left dumbstruck, completely and utterly lacking in comprehension of the machine engineered by a Wordsmith he'd never met.

Even as Raphael and Uzziel were trying to understand what they had just witnessed, less than ten seconds after gazing into Catherine's inner Mind Realm, they felt a terrifying force building up within her Mind Realm. A statue of Odin, situated directly in the center of her Mind Realm, began to glow with rage.

"INTRUDERS DETECTED. **GET OUT.**"

The statue suddenly flung its hands toward the tiny dots of perception high in the sky. Raphael cried out in terror as a mental attack blasted his and Uzziel's psychic links out of Catherine's Mind Realm and back into their bodies.

From the perspective of Gabriel and Camael, Raphael and Uzziel had only looked into Catherine's Mind Realm for mere seconds before they were suddenly sent tumbling backward, landing on their wings and banging the backs of their heads against the concrete.

"Aaargh!" Raphael cried, as even his usually robust mental abilities took a direct hit from whatever the hell was inside Catherine's head.

At the same time, with Raphael's mental defenses temporarily shattered, all the chains and bindings enveloping Catherine abruptly vanished. She awoke with a start and quickly sat up, looking around in shock as she recalled the last thing she'd seen, which was Raphael flickering forward to attack her. Then her vision had gone black and she'd woken up here.

"W-what in the Creator's name?!" Catherine exclaimed.

"Don't move." Gabriel said, quickly raising a palm filled with divine energy to point it at Catherine. "I know not what is happening, but thou hath wounded Raphael and

Uzziel."

"I wounded THEM?! Raphael attacked me!" Catherine argued, though she didn't make any sudden movements with the four Archangels around her. All of a sudden, she felt extremely exposed and vulnerable, surrounded by four of the mightiest existences in Heaven. If they wanted her dead, she didn't stand a snowball's chance in hell of staying alive.

Camael drew a sword from her waist. It was no Excalibur, but it was a powerful artifact in its own right.

"Make no moves." Camael warned. "Remain seated."

It took him a minute, but Raphael managed to stagger to his feet. He was woozy and dizzy. He had not prepared himself at all for such a powerful counter-attack, and what he had seen inside Catherine's mind scared the life out of him.

"The Titans?!" Raphael asked, as a storm of rage welled up on his face. "Thou hath betrayed us to side with the Titans?!"

"What? No." Catherine replied. "What gave you that idea?"

"I SAW IT!" Raphael roared, pointing a shaky finger at Catherine's head. "That beautiful, powerful, highly advanced Titan city built within thy Mind Realm! This old man has truly lived his live in vain for the Titans to craft such an exquisite artifact within thy Mind Realm, right under my nose! Who was it?! Tell me, which Titan has plotted against us? Was it Zeus? Neptune? Speak, child, or take thy secrets to thy grave!"

Catherine started to shake with fear. She had chosen the Titan-based MindCore at Jason's suggestion, and because it suited her needs. But now, she realized it was going to cause a terrible misunderstanding, and even cost her her life!

"N-no, Father! It wasn't the Titans! This isn't what you think..." Catherine pleaded.

Tears welled up in Catherine's eyes. It was only now, surrounded by beings she could never hope to defeat, that she realized she had greatly overestimated her capabilities. She thought she could lie to the man who knew her best, and now she was about to pay the price.

Despite all of this, she bit her tongue. She couldn't bring herself to divulge Jason's secrets. She had made a vow, and as a D'Arc sister, she couldn't break it... not even if it ended up costing her life.

Catherine cried. She lowered her head and heaved great sobs, no longer sure of what to say or how to save herself. This only made her look more guilty in the eyes of the Archangels.

"A traitor." Camael said, scowling. "After everything we've done for thee, this is thy repayment."

"What should we do?" Gabriel asked calmly. He did not have a strong emotional reaction to news of Catherine's betrayal, but then again, few things emotionally moved him.

"We have to execute her." Camael answered. "If it were not for Raphael's wisdom, we mayeth fallen for a truly wicked scheme."

"Nay!" Raphael shouted. "We must investigate this matter carefully. We must dig into the traitor's mind and uncover her secrets. If we can find out what the Titans are plotting, we mayeth save ourselves from a hidden calamity!"

Uzziel gingerly stepped over to Catherine's side. She wrung her hands and grimaced, hearing the words of her siblings. "N-no... I don't want to see little Catherine hurt... maybe this is all a misunderstanding, Raphael? She's always been such a good girl..."

"Cans't thou explaineth the majestic machine built within her Mind Realm?" Raphael asked pointedly. "Only a Titan artisan could craft such an incredible Mind Realm. Truly, I hath no knowledge of who might accomplish such a feat. But surely, if we comb the records, we shalt find a Titan concealing their true abilities."

A long silence followed, punctuated only by Catherine's sobbing.

It would be so easy to explain this problem away, but Catherine refused. She would never break her vow, even if it meant her own death.

She was scared, though. She didn't want to die. She was afraid of death, as anyone would be.

And if the Archangels truly picked at her brain, wouldn't they uncover the Wordsmith's existence anyway? Was there any point in causing herself undue pain and suffering when they would definitely get the answer in the end anyway?

Catherine cried. She wept. Her shoulders trembled and her body shook as she fought desperately against her urge to speak, to save herself.

After a long minute, Raphael sighed.

"Even now, she doth not speak. Loyal to the end."

His words were a mixture of praise and sadness. Once, that loyalty had been reserved for Heaven, and more specifically, for *him*. Now, though, it seemed she had passed her devotion on to someone else. A Titan, at that.

What a tragic loss.

As Raphael's anger cooled, his rationality returned, and he realized that now he would have to actually dive into Catherine's Mind Realm to find out just who had the capabilities to do this to her.

But, before Raphael could do so, a female voice spoke from the darkness within the edges of the room.

"It wasn't a Titan. It was *me*."

Raphael flinched. The other Archangels jumped.

In unison, they and Catherine all raised and turned their heads to quickly stare in the direction of where the unexpected voice had come from.

"W-who's there?!" Raphael asked, alarmed that someone had actually managed to sneak into the Archangel's executive hall without a single one of them noticing.

Camael raised her sword. Gabriel swiveled his body to aim a palm full of divine energy at the speaker.

From the shadows, a human woman stepped out. She had neck-length brown hair and green eyes, she wore glasses, and a smart blue suit-dress.

"Sorry to startle you." The woman said, her tone bland. "I wasn't going to interfere, but I felt I couldn't allow this abortion of justice to continue a second longer. My name is Jessica Harper. You would have heard about me sooner or later after my feats at Sarabiya. I am a Lowborn, and my title is the Great Builder. I am the one who constructed Catherine's Mind Realm."

Catherine's heart jumped. Her eyes flickered. She instantly realized this was a deception. She knew it was Jason who had operated on her, and by comprehending some of the concepts behind his powers, she also instantly realized he must be able to disguise himself.

But was Jason Hiro the disguise, or was Jessica Harper? Catherine didn't know. She intuitively though Jason must have turned himself into Jessica Harper to fool the others, but she wasn't *entirely* sure.

She decided to stay quiet. It was a good thing, too, because clearly, Jessica had come prepared.

"Thou?" Raphael questioned. "Thou art the one who created Catherine's Mind Realm?"

Even though it seemed as if he were merely repeating Jessica's words, Raphael actually was completely bewildered. When in the god damn did a human Hero come into the picture? Lucifer corrupting Catherine made sense, and a betrayal by the Titans also followed the train of logic in his mind.

But a human Hero? When did one of them get involved??

And furthermore, how could a mere Lowborn craft such an exquisite Mind Realm? It made no sense!

"I did not intend to speak to you until after the coming battle in Heaven, as revealing my existence goes against my plans." Jessica said, crossing her arms. "However, seeing as you were about to cause great harm to the woman who saved my life, I realized I had to intervene."

Jessica waved her hand, causing a large table and six chairs to materialize. Enough for the four Archangels, herself, and Catherine.

Raphael's eyes went as wide as saucers. He could conjure illusions of a table and chairs, and Uzziel could create wooden versions by growing them out of the ground, but to instantly create them on the spot with a wave of her hand? This woman might be the real deal!

"Everyone, come and take a seat." Jessica said, as she sat at the head of the table and conjured tea and crumpets for the others to eat.

"We have a lot to discuss."

Part 769: Heaven's First Battle

January 29th, 2021. Heaven, inside the Archangel's Assembly Chambers.

None of the angels, Titans, or Lazarites outside knew it, but a momentous and historic meeting was taking place during the hours of preparation before dawn, the same day as the demons were planning a bloody invasion and assault into Heaven's borders.

The four living Archangels had accosted Catherine, intending to imprison her for betraying Heaven, only for a human woman to somehow suddenly appear in their midst, calling herself a Lowborn, but also a representative of the Trueborns, authorized to speak on their behalf.

Her name was Jessica Harper, and while she was actually a 'mere' split soul belonging to Jason Hiro, nobody in the chambers knew the truth of the matter except for Catherine, who only suspected the truth.

Catherine shakily stood up and stood behind the Archangels, staring intently as they strode over and sat at the table across from Jessica Harper. Seeing the cups of tea that had magically appeared, as well as the table itself, the Archangels were examining her with great interest.

"The Great Builder." Raphael repeated, as he took a sip from the cup. The tea could potentially be poisoned, even to the extent of affecting his physique, but he wasn't too worried. The fact Jessica had declared that Catherine had saved her life almost certainly meant she was not hostile to the Archangels' interests and would not stoop to such a level as poisoning them. "If thou art so 'great', then why hath thy title yet to reach my ears?"

"I didn't pick my title." Jessica said. "It was chosen for me by those who saw my powers in action."

Raphael nodded. "Thou stateth that the Daughter of Heaven saved thy life. Under what circumstances did this happen?"

Behind the Archangels, Catherine felt a cold, icy sensation wash over her skin. She knew she'd never met 'Jessica' in her life. Anything Jessica would say was surely a lie. How could she hope to fool the wisest Archangel alive?

"I was at Catherine's Monastery." Jessica said. "I was sent there by the Trueborn, Cat Mask, to prepare for the demon attack we knew was coming, but the attack came too swiftly and caught me by surprise. Right when the demons were about to kill me, the Daughter of Heaven swooped down and killed my assailant. She was attacked by Emperor Lucifer, and I managed to pull us both out of there."

"Thou possesseth the ability to flee from Lucifer, yet thou were helpless against lesser demons?" Raphael asked, his sharp eyes poking holes in Jessica's story.

"That's right." Jessica said, not even flinching under Raphael's questioning. "Well, 'helpless' is a strong word. Given enough time to prepare, I can adapt to most situations. But a sneak attack is a sneak attack, and my abilities were not much help when the Battle Brothers arrived to capture me. Even Cat Mask had no idea they were coming, or if he did, he didn't tell me."

Camael leaned forward, opting to speak before Raphael could. "This individual, Cat Mask, verily we hath heard his name of late, but we know not who he is. Coulds't thou describe him?"

"He used to keep his abilities a secret, but I guess he decided to experiment recently, try something new." Jessica said, the slightest hint of annoyance in her voice. "Maybe it's a form of psychological warfare designed to mess with the minds of the demons. Anyway, you'll hear about him sooner or later, so I don't mind telling you now."

She paused for a moment.

"Cat Mask is a temporal manipulator. He possesses the ability to rewind and alter time as he pleases, and in doing so, he has rewound time millions, billions, maybe even trillions of times. Nobody knows how many years he's spent reliving the next 70 or so years on Earth, perhaps not even him. Apparently, he made a big change in the current 'causal loop' we're experiencing now, which has caused the rapid emergence of Lowborn Heroes, and he also imbued his own son with the power of a Trueborn Hero."

"What?" Raphael gasped. "A second Trueborn? Dost thou speaketh the truth?"

"Since the demons have already learned of his abilities, it won't hurt if I tell you... but I don't know all the details." Jessica said with a sigh. "He's known as the Archseer, and his power is called Dream Eating. He can devour the dreams of other entities to learn of their plans and to empower himself. He took the knowledge of an unknown demon and became a master of hand-to-hand combat at only age eighteen, for instance. He has been

combining his power with his father's, and in this way, the two of them have quickly built a huge intelligence network."

Raphael slowly nodded. He digested Jessica's words with great caution, thinking about the implications and pondering how they would affect his own plans.

"Despite being a man who knows the future, Cat Mask did not foresee thy attack at the Monastery?" Camael questioned. "This point is far too suspicious. Are we to believe he was so careless with a valuable asset?"

"Nay." Raphael said quietly. "Tis beyond reason. It seems 'Cat Mask' has designs on Heaven, for he arranged the meeting between the 'Great Builder' and the Daughter of Heaven."

"I may be part of the Trueborn's inner circle, but there are plenty of things they don't tell me." Jessica said. "I also believe the Trueborns planned for me to be there, but they did not tell me the demons would attack early, so I truly thought I was going to die. When Catherine saved my life, I was grateful to her, and I asked her how my powers could help. Thus, after some effort, I came to the conclusion that empowering her with a superior Mind Realm would be the best way to repay her."

Raphael glanced back at Catherine. He didn't say anything, but she could see that there was a question in his eyes. As if confirming something to himself just by seeing the look on her face, he returned his gaze back to Jessica and nodded to himself. Neither woman knew what the old fox was thinking.

"Well. Thou art here, and it seems thou intendeth to protect Catherine. I appreciate those who value friendship." Raphael said solemnly. "Thou hath told me a bit about the two Trueborn, but what about thyself? What sort of woman art thou? What powers dost thou commandeth?"

"My powers..." Jessica said, her tone slightly hesitant, "...are quite formidable. I am not the only Lowborn of this generation with abilities beyond those of our predecessors, but admittedly, mine could be considered a tier above the rest. For example..."

She motioned with her hands, causing a thin metal rectangle to appear on the table between herself and the Archangels. Immediately, all their eyes locked onto the strange object.

"This is...?" Uzziel asked.

Jessica didn't immediately answer. Instead, she reached over and poked her thumbs into the side of the rectangle, then lifted what turned out to be a 'lid' of some sort.

The lid flipped up to reveal... something. None of the Archangels knew what they were even looking at. There was a glossy flat spot recessed inside the flipped-up lid, and a bunch of letters, numbers, and symbols arrayed inside the bottom part.

"This is a laptop computer." Jessica explained. "Do any of you recognize it?"

The Archangels slowly shook their heads. Even Raphael, who had definitely seen computers at a few points in the last 50 years, wasn't up to date on them. For him, 50 years was like the blink of an eye. He simply couldn't keep up with human technological advancements, and he also didn't interact much with the newest Lazarites who would know.

"Computers can do all sorts of things." Jessica said, before directing her eyes in Camael's direction. "They're similar to your sentient artifacts, like Excalibur. Internal circuitry, not dissimilar to the internal magical matrices used to create your most powerful artifacts."

"Thou art familiar... with my work?" Camael asked in confusion.

"I've had a chance to look at Jepthath's staff, as well as Arthur's sword. I'm not too familiar with their internals, but I know they're complex enough to be fairly similar to human technology. At least in the broadest of strokes... naturally the minutiae will differ."

Camael was enlightened. "Art we to understand thy abilities are similar to mine, in thy own human way?"

"Yes. That's basically correct. My internal mana storage is quite limited, but I was able to increase it by building bigger and bigger mana batteries inside a secret location, which I have connected to my soul remotely, and some other stuff that you and I might be able to talk about if we have time later. But that time is not now, as the demons will attack soon and I cannot stay here long."

Raphael looked back and forth from his sister to the Lowborn Hero. He could tell that Camael's interest had been piqued, as her blacksmithing identity meant more to her than any other part of her personality. Camael was practically a slave to her creative thirst, and she would shut herself off from the world for decades at a time while working on a new

artifact, often using her seer powers to portend the future and make weapons suited for future Heroes, Titans, and Angels alike.

Raphael frowned, ever so slightly. It was important that Camael remain in Heaven, never getting too excited by whatever nonsense the humans and other lesser species were working on. A few notable blacksmiths had appeared across human history, but none of them had ever forged artifacts at Camael's level, so to her they were little more than juniors with middling potential. Since they all died of old age in a hundred years or less, she barely had time to notice them before their flames flickered out like candles in the wind.

But Jessica appeared quite young. If she was already forging artifacts capable of catching Camael's eye, she might have several good decades to draw the Archangel's eyes away from Heaven. This was not something Raphael wished to see.

"Fascinating indeed." Raphael said, taking care to switch topics and not linger too long on Jessica's previous words. "But we have not yet discussed the fact that thou hath granted a formidable boon to Catherine while surreptitiously asking her to hide thy handiwork. What art thy intentions, young one? Why doth thou sneaketh behind our backs in such a snake-like manner?"

"I didn't anticipate you'd be able to see through Catherine's Mind Realm so quickly." Jessica said, not bothering to deny his accusation. "I'm not out here trying to advertise my capabilities, you know. They will become known sooner rather than later, but the longer I can keep them under wraps, and the fewer who know of my abilities, the stronger a foundation I can build."

Gabriel tilted his head. "Foundation? What is thy meaning?"

"I am the Great Builder. I build things." Jessica said simply. "I haven't even begun to build at my highest possible level. I might soon craft weapons capable of rendering the demons helpless. I could elevate humanity to a tremendously mightier level in the coming years, allowing us to stand as a bulwark against the greater Threats inside and outside the galaxy."

Raphael's eyes flashed. "What Threats dost thou speak of? What dost thou know of Threats outside the galaxy?"

Jessica crossed her arms and directed a pointed glare at Raphael. "You know exactly what I'm talking about."

Raphael and Jessica's eyes met. Sparks seemingly flew between them as she easily matched his glare with one of her own. Raphael's heart skipped a beat. He could tell the young woman was not bluffing. But how did she know? When did humanity acquire knowledge of the Threats outside their own small world?

Surprisingly, it wasn't Raphael who spoke next, but Camael. "Thou speaketh of the Akashic Barrier?"

"That's right." Jessica said, slyly smiling as she jerked her eyes over to the old woman. "We have at least 100,000 more years before the Akashic Barrier falls. That's plenty of time for humanity to create contingency plans. The angels too, if you're interested. Maybe the Titans, the Demons, and the other species as well. All this infighting on one little world is only making our future situation worse."

By this point, Raphael's heart had jumped five or six times. His skin turned cold as he listened to the woman before him speaking. How in the god-damn did she know about the Akashic Barrier? Raphael had always been careful to keep knowledge of it limited to the highest ranking Titans, and the Archangels. He knew for a fact such information had not leaked to the demons yet, and the humans had barely even managed to step foot off-planet, only exploring their local moon and other worlds with probes and such.

How did the humans know? When did they learn of such matters?!

Jessica smiled sweetly at Raphael, but her eyes were filled with mockery. It made Raphael realize, or at least think of the possibility, that there was a mole in Heaven. Had one of the Lazarites chanced upon this information and passed it to the humans?

That line of thinking made him consider that Catherine had betrayed Heaven, but just as quickly as the possibility arrived, he cast it aside. Catherine was a formidable Lazarite, but matters relating to the Cosmic Scale were above her station. Neither Raphael nor the other Archangels would discuss the Akashic Barrier with her. She was not entitled to such information.

But if Catherine had not betrayed Heaven, then how had the humans learned of this information?!

It truly confounded him. The simple and plain-looking woman before him suddenly seemed wrapped in mystery, larger than life. Was she truly only a Lowborn?

At this moment, Raphael had a revelation.

"The Trueborn..." Raphael muttered. "Thou stated before that Cat Mask was... a time traveler?"

"Oh yes, he's seen many different versions of future events play out." Jessica said. "I'm sure you're wondering how we know about the matters of Akasha? I don't actually know how he came by the information, but perhaps you and him became best friends in another life, and you let the matter slip? It's hard to say."

Raphael paled. Was it possible? Was *he* the one who had casually tossed such sensitive information to this lowly, primitive species? It wasn't as if there were Akashic Laws against doing such a thing, but knowledge was power, and simply blabbering about these things was giving up future leverage for free! It was a deeply unwise move!

What Raphael did not know was that at that very moment, Jessica, AKA Jason, was dealing with a headache of his own. He didn't really want to be informing Raphael that his father was a time traveler. In fact, Jason didn't want anyone to know, especially not the angels and demons!

But his goddamned dad had gone and yapped about his powers to Ose, of all demons. Ose! The most manipulative, evil piece of shit Jason could imagine! Now that she knew, the other Emperors knew, and before long word would get around to the angels, including Raphael.

Thus, Jason was forced to reveal knowledge of his father's powers to one of the people he least wanted to know. It was beyond undesirable, but by giving up this information willingly, Jason would benefit in a few key ways.

Firstly, he would appear more honest and frank to Raphael. He could reveal the information on his own terms and force Raphael onto the back-foot.

Secondly, Jason could control the narrative and twist the information to his advantage.

Thirdly, Jessica would become mysterious, and behind her, Cat Mask and the Archseer would become shrouded in a fog of deception.

Cat Mask, especially, would become an enigma, making the angels and demons second and third-guess their every moves. They would constantly wonder if they were bumbling into a trap Cat Mask had laid for them, or doing something he already knew was coming and had handily prepared for.

What none of them would know was... Cat Mask didn't give a shit about any of this!

Right now, Cat Mask wasn't helping his son at all. He wasn't feeding Jason knowledge of future events, and even if he wanted to, Jason's time traveling had drastically changed the timeline, so all of Cat Masks's previous knowledge had become outdated and unreliable.

...But the angels and demons didn't need to know that part. Once Raphael learned of Ose's battle against Cat Mask, he would know that the humans were telling the truth about Cat Mask's power, and he would be forced into a passive role, uncertain of what actions to take moving forward.

In essence, Jason allowed his lazy father to take on the role of a mysterious powerhouse, drawing everyone's attention to him.

The crazy thing was, it sure as hell wasn't Cat Mask who had told Jason about the Akashic Barrier. In matters of the Cosmos, Cat Mask was totally ignorant. He'd never heard of the True Cosmic Realm, he didn't know about the Akashic Barrier, and he didn't even know about the Archdemon! It seemed that even with Cat Mask's billions of years of life, he hadn't thought about anything besides saving Earth, or at least humanity as a whole. Matters of the cosmos had always been outside his purview, and beyond what even his time-rewinding powers would allow him to affect, so he had never given them much thought.

Thus, it was not Cat Mask, but instead Jason who came from the future and knew of Cosmic matters. He had been the one to educate his father, but now he was using his father as a prop to draw attention away from himself.

It was sneaky, it was effective, and it *worked*. If Raphael did think of Jason, he would simply assume Jason had used his Dream Eating powers to learn of the Cosmic Realm and other such things. But, more likely, Raphael would focus his attention on the time traveler leading humanity.

And so, after Jessica answered, Raphael was left lost and confused, unsure of what to do. By now, he had mentally forgiven Catherine and no longer thought about her so-called betrayal even a little bit. If she did betray Heaven, that much was only natural. It was likely that the damnable time traveler had investigated her in a forgotten future timeline and used his knowledge to bamboozle her! Clearly, that must be the case, for

he'd even swindled Raphael out of knowledge Raphael didn't remember telling him about!

If the Archangel of Wisdom could be fooled by such a slick-talking time traveler, what hope did poor little Catherine have? She was not at fault.

"I... I see." Raphael said, his heart heavy. "Verily, this ancient one hath lived a life in vain. The new Trueborn duo make for quite the formidable pair."

"We're not your enemies." Jessica said. "Humanity, I mean. You angels live here in Heaven, hiding away from the real world, living a lie forged from ancient pain that secretly burns your soul every day. But it doesn't have to be like this. You hide your existence from humanity and puppeteer its leaders from the shadows, but why? Symbiosis is possible, certainly preferable to the lonely lives you lead now."

She glanced toward the door leading outside, the movements of her eyes intentional and calculated. "By the numbers, Heaven is, what, 90% Lazarites, 9% Titans, and less than 1% Pureblooded Angels? The Lazarites have turned Heaven into a laughable imitation of their former human world. If you survive this war, I believe it might be possible to deepen the friendship between humanity and angelkind. With my abilities, especially, we might be able to solve some major problems holding both sides' development back."

"Such as?" Uzziel asked, speaking up for the first time in a while.

"Well, the mana problem, for one. I imagine with billions of Lazarites, managing all their mana must be difficult. There's only eight billion humans on Earth, and the meager Faith Energy they generate is made lesser by the fact a large number of them are atheists, and even the believers themselves aren't too devout, only praying occasionally. These problems are solvable by me."

The underside of Raphael's eye twitched. "For a substantial price, no doubt. This ancient one doth not believe such favors shalt come cheaply or freely."

"It won't matter right now." Jessica said, neither confirming nor denying his words. "You have to beat back the demons and survive before you even start thinking of thriving. Cat Mask does not want to see Heaven fall. Are we authorized to enter and assist you in the coming battle?"

Raphael hesitated.

His mind revolved at lightning speed as a great many concerns piled upon his lap all at once.

Two possibilities immediately emerged in his mind. First, there was the matter of whether or not Jessica was being truthful, especially about one particular point.

Was Cat Mask a time traveler, as she stated?

The answer to that question had a heavy bearing on what he should say next.

It seemed likely that Cat Mask was a time traveler, but Raphael would not be able to determine if he was or wasn't unless Cat Mask came and demonstrated his powers right before the old man's eyes.

If Cat Mask was not a time traveler, then this meant Jessica was deceiving him. Why? Perhaps to place people inside Heaven and strike at Raphael when his guard was down? Perhaps to assassinate other key figures within Heaven?

If Cat Mask *was* a time traveler though, then this presented its own issues. Had Cat Mask spoken to Raphael in a previous timeline? Had he engineered Jessica's responses to Raphael's questions to achieve exactly the result he wanted? If he had, then would Raphael rejecting Jessica's offer become a major problem for the Archangel of Wisdom down the line? Maybe rejecting her would allow Cat Mask to say to the human leaders 'Well, I tried!' and this would drive a wedge between Heaven and Earth.

But then again, maybe saying yes to her offer was what Cat Mask wanted? Maybe all of this was designed just to nudge Raphael in the direction the mysterious Trueborn wanted?

Raphael tried not to let his anxiety show, but he was sweating on the inside. This was all so sudden, it had sprang on him out of nowhere, and he had never seen Cat Mask in person. All he had to go off was the man's silly-sounding Heroic moniker, and that was truly nothing at all.

Was it possible Cat Mask had engineered everything, including Catherine's slip-up in Raphael's quarters, for this moment? Was 'this moment' even all that important? Maybe this was just a setup for an even more dangerous future gambit, and whatever Raphael chose now was rather unimportant and it was what came later that would truly test Heaven's foundation.

These thoughts, and many others, came to Raphael in a flash, a single second of thinking time. His face twisted slightly at Jessica's words, but he succeeded in not fully baring his emotions before her.

Raphael had no way of knowing, but Jessica was just as worried as he was! Jason puppeteered Jessica, having no idea about what Raphael's answer would be. Jason had his guesses, and he was mixing in lies with truth at a ratio of 20% lies and 80% truth, but he did fear Raphael would see through his gambit. Luckily for him, the information he'd given Raphael was so overwhelming with potential consequences, along with the looming threat of the demon invasion, that Raphael simply didn't have the time or mental capacity to carefully evaluate everything Jessica had told him.

If Raphael had the time and energy, he'd surely have spotted several more issues with her words and attempted to poke holes in her story. But with Jessica constantly reminding him of the impending doom at his doorstep, Raphael begrudgingly had to come to a decision, and quickly.

"Thou art... authorized." Raphael said slowly. He quickly firmed his tone as he made the decision. "Heaven is in need of allies at this crucial time. Naturally, we shan't forget those who reach out to us with good intentions. We art not an ungrateful people."

It didn't escape Jason's notice that Raphael had deliberately mentioned 'good intentions' as a caveat in case Jason's intentions turned out to not be entirely pure or in Heaven's best interests... but the Wordsmith had no desire to call the old man out on this minor point. Raphael was clearly grasping at straws.

"Good, good. I'm glad to hear that." Jessica said. "Since you've agreed, we'll move fast to limit the damage the demons can inflict. I've already begun building specialized counter-weapons for some of the most dangerous demons. I haven't had time to build all of them, but if we can take out the highest-threat targets, we'll be able to avert the coming crisis with minimal casualties."

Raphael nodded solemnly. He felt as if he had exchanged blows in the first moments of the coming war, and he had come up short. His opponent, this unexpected young Lowborn, had outmaneuvered him.

It wasn't a death-blow by any means, but Jessica had seized the initiative and momentarily left Raphael at a loss for what to do. He would have to move quickly to

regather his momentum in the coming period, or else she would continue pushing deeper and deeper into his territory.

"Catherine, come sit beside me." Jessica said, gesturing to the seat on her right. "You will be quite important during the battles to come."

Raphael flinched, but he said nothing. Once again, Jessica had struck another blow, taking advantage of his attack on Catherine to alienate her a little further from Heaven's interests. The worst part was that if Raphael had apologized sooner, if he had spoken before Jessica, he might have been the one to get in Catherine's good graces and reduce the damage of his actions from earlier.

But now, as Catherine walked over and sat beside Jessica, Raphael realized that she did not seem hesitant in the least. It appeared she and Jessica had quite a close relationship... and Raphael had inadvertently pushed her away.

Should he apologize now, with all the others looking? Would it come off as performative and perfunctory? Or should he wait until later, to make the apology seem more genuine?

"My apologies for what the words I spake earlier." Raphael quickly said, humbly bowing his head. "Verily, I hath wronged you, young one. I should have known thou were an upright woman of good moral standing. Thou woulds't never think of betraying Heaven."

Jessica's eye twitched. Raphael had indeed apologized, but he also sneakily tried to guilt-trip Catherine a little, 'reminding' her of where her allegiances should lie.

"Yes, you *should* have known that much." Jessica quickly retorted, speaking before Catherine could say a word. "But speaking of Catherine not betraying Heaven, was it not Heaven's leader who betrayed her first? I suppose 600 years of affection doesn't mean much to an ancient creature of the primordial times. Our human lives are so fleeting and forgettable, after all."

"It's fine." Catherine said, quickly raising her palm. "Thank you for the apology, Raphael. I am also sorry that I deceived you before. I made a promise to... Jessica... and I didn't want to break it."

"Thou hath always been good at keeping thy word. Thou dost cherish thy vows deeply." Raphael said, raising his head to smile warmly at her. He ignored Jessica's

previous barb. Now was not the time to exchange insults, for it would make him seem the lesser man at the table.

Jessica resisted the urge to roll her eyes. Once again, Raphael couldn't help but bring up 'vows' to try and guilt-trip Catherine. But it was fine, as Jessica had already called him out once. Catherine was not so stupid as to be unable to see through the hidden meaning in his words, especially after having it pointed out once before.

"Time is running out." Jessica said, waving her hand to turn the laptop computer she'd made into dust, before reforming it into a map of the outer Sinai countryside. "Let us discuss strategy, and how humanity's military can best assist Heaven in this coming war."

"This ancient one would be deeply appreciative." Raphael said, smiling at Jessica as well.

None present but Raphael himself knew what schemes were cooking inside his twisted old mind...

Part 770: Strategic Objectives

January 29th, 2021. Heaven, inside the Archangel's Assembly Chambers.

Thirty long minutes passed. Jessica Harper continued to converse with the angels, causing the expressions on their faces to oscillate between grimness and worry as she spoke. The Archangels were simultaneously quite knowledgeable about humans and yet distressingly ignorant.

If one were to ask who knew humans 'the best' it would likely be a tie between Uzziel and Raphael. Camael didn't converse with them much, and Gabriel kept to himself, rarely chatting with the Lazarites, and even less frequently leaving Heaven.

Uzziel was the creator of humankind. She had a vested interest in her 'children' and she always talked with the Lazarites, learning how humans worked and so on.

Raphael was the brain of Heaven, and as such he sometimes communicated with humans on Earth. This was rarely done in person, and Raphael frequently used illusory decoys, liaisons inside Earth's churches, and so on.

Over the years, Raphael almost exclusively only spoke with the current Pope of the Roman Catholic Church, and other high level leaders in the other major religions. They knew of his existence, and the truth behind angelkind, but they were sworn to secrecy, enjoying the promise of immortality after death and holding a high rank among the Lazarites post-death. They had every reason to stay loyal to Raphael and pursue his interests, as it matched their own interests.

At the same time, Raphael would also, ever so occasionally, speak to the leaders of certain Orders among the humans. Not the Illuminati, who were devoted human supremacists, but a few of the other ones, such as the Knights Templar.

The problem was, Raphael and Uzziel, knowledgeable about humans though they might believe themselves to be, were extremely ignorant when it came to matters of modern human capabilities.

Weapons. Guns. Drones. Intercontinental ballistic missiles.

Vehicles. Armored tanks, land rovers. Flying machines. Underwater submarines and topside destroyers.

Warfare tactics. Guerilla warfare, suburban combat, desert skirmishes.

The angels knew very little of these things. Raphael was aware, in the abstract, that humans had grown more powerful, and he was a little leery of them, but a hundred years meant nothing to an entity who had lived for billions. In the blink of an eye, humanity had skyrocketed in their capability to deal out death and destruction, and it had happened seemingly in a single instant when he looked away then looked back.

Thus, when Jessica offered for humans to 'help' the Archangels, Raphael and the rest did not agree because they thought the human's assistance would be all that helpful.

Oh, by no means.

Instead, the clever Archangel of Wisdom thought to use the humans as meatshields, living bodies that would support the Lazarites, and would allow the Archangels to fight the 'real' battle comfortably.

All that changed in less than thirty minutes as Jessica Harper started explaining her plans to the old man. She conjured an overhead projection of Mount Sinai and the surrounding thirty kilometers of land in any direction atop the table, giving the Archangels a bird's eye view of the battlefield.

"In phase three, we will send in the military forces of Europe from the north. To summarize, I've received authorization to deploy two platoons of Finnish soldiers across this river here, and they will be flanked by a sky division from Norway raining gunfire from above to keep the demons from taking to the skies."

"At the same time, arriving from the west, Egypt's security forces don't want to let other countries make them look like fools, so they will be naturally working alongside the United States to send in these fifteen detachments from the northwest, the west, and the southwest in a pincer formation. This is a diagram of the tank-type you'll be seeing them field the most heavily. It's a fairly robust model, one I plan to overhaul and improve when I have time, but no demon below the rank of Baron will even be able to dent it, so it's sufficient for our purposes."

Jessica drew lines with her fingers, smirking internally as the Archangel's faces turned a slightly miserable shade of gray. Uzziel was at a loss for words, she didn't even understand the terms Jessica was using, and Raphael was struggling mightily as he had no idea that 'tanks' had evolved so fast. The last time he'd seen one was during World War

II, the last time the angels materially contributed to a war on Earth, and those ancient clunky rolling machines were far less threatening than their modern counterparts.

"H-hold a moment, if thou mayest..." Raphael said, massaging his tired eyelids. He felt a million years older after listening to her speak. "Is the meaning of thy words to imply the humans shalt fight the hardest battles against the demons? Even with two Trueborn, this ancient one feelest thou mayest be overestimating thy capabilities. The demons art numerous, and their Emperors outnumber thy Heroes twenty to one!"

"If Cat Mask has to fight twenty Demon Emperors at once, he'll definitely die." Jessica acknowledged. "The same is true for the Archseer. But why would we ever do something so foolish as fighting under those conditions? And furthermore, we aren't fighting a battle with the intention of exterminating the Demon Emperors, or even their lesser minions. That has nothing to do with our tactical strategy."

"It... doesn't?" Raphael asked, before realizing what she meant. "Ah. Thy intentions art simply to repel the demons from Sinai and prevent them from entering Heaven."

"That won't be possible." Jessica said, shaking her head. "We have less than a day to assemble the human military forces. This simply isn't enough time to logistically accomplish a perfect defense of Heaven. Instead, we're just trying to make the demons feel enough fear of the humans that they pull out before they can suffer losses extreme enough to cripple their future power."

Raphael blinked. He stared at the projection for a long minute in silence.

"If the demon leaders experience a tactical loss, it mayest undermine their minions' morale." Raphael said thoughtfully. "Therefore, thy assault art simply... a bluff?"

"Not a bluff at all. If the humans get serious, the demons will suffer a terrible loss. Even with such limited time to prepare, we can wound them badly, and that will magnify our threat in their minds." Jessica explained. "Think of it like us giving them a taste of what we're capable, and they will thusly realize what we've brought to this battle is but a tiny fraction of what we *could* unleash in the future. That will make them think twice before attacking Heaven again."

"Indeed..." Raphael said slowly. "Before attacking *Heaven* again..."

It did not escape his notice that the truth of the matter was that the humans had pulled a fast one on him. They had taken advantage of the holes in his knowledge and

were going to use the coming battle as a way to showcase their strength. Any gains Heaven might obtain would thus become 'conditional' to their relations with humanity.

So long as Heaven and the humans were allied, the strength of humanity was the angel's as well.

But if those relations should ever begin to cool...

Raphael did not speak aloud regarding his misgivings, but Jessica could see the wariness in his eyes. The Archangel and Lowborn silently chose not to pursue the discussion in that direction any further. Her threat was subtle enough that if he were to call it out, it would make him appear ungrateful during his time of need. A favor granted to an ally now could always be paid back later, so long as the recipient continued to live, and thus Raphael decided in that moment he would accept the human's generosity, but he would not allow them to dangle the debt over his head.

As soon as he could, Raphael would pay back this debt to return their standing to a more neutral level.

"Verily, thou intendeth to encircle the demons." Camael said, studying the topographical map of Sinai. "But dost thou not worry this battle could cost many humans their lives?"

"If some soldiers die, that would be unfortunate, but they will revive as warriors fighting for you, our allies." Jessica said, smiling sweetly at Camael. "Reborn into undying angelic bodies, this hardly even counts as death in my eyes. We will do what we can to minimize the casualties, but converting living soldiers into Lazarites is an acceptable trade if it scares the daylights out of the demons."

"Is there any manner in which we mayest assist thee?" Gabriel asked.

"No. You Archangels are needed in Heaven." Jessica answered. "Doubtless, the Demon Emperors have some objective they are pursuing, likely cutting off the head of Raphael. Stick together and guard one another well. We humans will handle the outside assault, but it will be up to Heaven to guard its inner area. You can manage at least that much, yes?"

Raphael's eye twitched. "Of course. We art Archangels!"

"Very well. Then that concludes our strategy meeting. I hope that a week from now we'll all be sipping champagne over the demon's losses."

Jessica stood up, her strategy session concluded. Having gone over the broad strokes with the Archangels, she had impressed upon them humanity's current military strength. Even if not in the most minute detail, she had shown them the general capabilities of what her species had achieved militarily. It was up to the Archangels to heed her words and take her seriously.

Raphael and the others rose along with her. Without missing a beat, Jessica waved her hand, causing the table and chairs she had summoned to vanish into thin air, returning the chamber to its former state of emptiness.

"It was good meeting you all." Jessica said casually. "I'll be departing now. Let's talk again after the coming battle."

"How dids't thou enter Heaven's space and even manage to break inside our chambers without our noticing?" Camael asked, narrowing her eyes at the young human before her. "This question has been playing at the back of my mind since thy arrival."

"I built a device that can teleport myself and others across vast distances." Jessica replied without missing a beat. "Breaching Heaven's dimension was a little tricky, but it turns out Raphael's barrier strengthening attempts weren't enough to keep me out. You'd better hope the same isn't true for the demons, or their Warpers might sneak backdoors into Heaven after they invade."

"Indeed... we thank thee for thy timely warning." Raphael said, his mouth forming a smile that didn't quite meet his eyes.

With a short bow, Jessica waved her hand and disappeared, leaving the Archangels behind with Catherine.

Catherine's heart jumped when Raphael and the others turned to face her, but the barrage of questions she expected didn't come. Instead, Raphael sighed softly and lowered his head in contrition.

"Catherine. Truly, I hath wronged thee. My shame is boundless." Raphael said quietly. "For me to accuse thee of betraying Heaven when thou woulds't never do such a thing... I know not how such thoughts entered my mind. Perhaps I have begun to feel more stressed regarding the demon's attack than I previously thought. If there doth be any way in which I can make it up to thee..."

"That... that isn't necessary, Father." Catherine said, quickly bowing her head. "In the end, I did deceive you. I'm sorry. You're so wise, you were easily able to see through my childish attempt at hiding the truth. I'm in awe of your capabilities."

"Go out and prepare for the coming battle." Raphael said, as he walked over to rest a hand on her shoulder. "We will speak of my error in the future, assuming Heaven survives the coming battle. If it does not, then... I hope thou shalt surviveth and live a good life in my absence."

Catherine's heart felt like it was tying itself in knots. Her anxiety levels jumped at Raphael's words, but she couldn't bring herself to argue with him. Like this, she simply nodded her head, then turned and strode out of the meeting chambers, leaving the four Archangels alone.

A long minute passed as the four Archangels looked at one another.

"That Jessica..." Camael started to speak. "Verily, when I gazeth upon her-"

"We should inform Michael of what has transpired." Raphael interrupted, shooting a strange look at Camael. "He was not awake for these proceedings. He deserveth to know."

"Ah... alright, then. *We?*" Camael repeated. "Is it not thyself who usually informeth Michael of major events?"

"Long has it been since all of us hath gathered to speak to Michael." Raphael explained, his words as smooth as butter. "Since a potential dawn of doom draw neareth, we mayest all gather together one last time. Let us not risk falling without speaking to him in person."

"A sensible decision..." Camael said, shooting Raphael a strange look of her own.

To say Raphael's sudden request was unexpected would be an understatement. Since Michael's death 2,000 years before, only Raphael had communicated with him. Raphael wore two rings on his fingers; one was his own, and one was Michael's.

Each of the other three Archangels also wore a ring of their own. These had been forged by Camael some time after the War In Heaven, and served as one last chance for them to save their lives if their enemies should kill them. Even if their bodies died, they could retreat into the rings and potentially survive until the end of the Eternity.

This was the case for Michael when he sacrificed himself to empower the Lazarus Tower 2,000 years before...

With this, Raphael smiled kindly, like an old man who was looking forward to meeting his beloved grandson one last time. Raphael held up his right fist, revealing his ring and Michael's ring.

Camael held up her right fist as well and pressed the side of her pinky against Raphael's thumb. Then Gabriel pressed his giant fist against Camael's, and Uzziel pressed her fist into the gap between Gabriel and Raphael's fist.

Like this, their fists formed a square. The energy within their rings transformed into a powerful burst of energy in the center, and they felt their souls being tugged toward a domain of Thought, outside time and space...

Their vision darkened, then brightened once more. All four Archangels found themselves in a liminal space filled with golden light beaming off shining candelabras. In the center of a church-like building, there was an open coffin where a winged male was laying on his back, his arms crossed atop a sword resting on his chest. A shaft of light fell from a stained glass window, resting upon his body and granting him the appearance of a hero from another reality.

Emotions swelled within the breasts of Gabriel, Camael, and Uzziel, who were finally seeing the proper visage of their brother Michael, for the first time in 2,000 years.

"Michael..." Camael said quietly.

She walked over and brushed her sleeping brother's hair with a single finger, the motion so loving and tender it could make a grown man cry. Then she looked at Raphael.

"How do we awaken him?" Camael asked.

Raphael looked at her sternly. "We don't."

"Huh?" Camael asked, confused.

"Heaven is no longer a place where we can speak freely." Raphael said, his tone becoming menacing. "That... that woman... 'Jessica'. There is something deeply *wrong* with her."

Uzziel blinked. "Wrong? Wait... so we hath not come to awaken Michael?"

"Nay. I needed to spin a tale capable of confusing outside observers. Even now, I know not if our words art not still being intercepted. This domain is shielded by my powerful mind, and verily I shoulds't senseth any who dare to intrude. But any level of secrecy can

no longer be guaranteed, even in here. For now, tis' the best I could come up with in so short a time."

The other three Archangels fell silent. Gabriel stroked his chin, then he nodded to himself.

"Ah. Thou art truly the wisest of us, brother. Now that I think back on our meeting with that Jessica, I remembereth the manner in which she arrived. How coulds't she have known what we were discussing unless she were also able to spy on us?"

Camael sucked in a sharp breath. "Is this thy meaning, Raphael? The humans hath found a way to spy on Heaven? Even in our most secretive areas?"

"Indeed." Raphael said, his expression as dark as the Void. He scowled angrily as he thought about how that vixen had toyed with him from the very beginning. "Jessica and the Trueborns hath begun to turn Catherine against us. This much should be obvious for any of thee to see, but tis' far from our biggest concern. What worries me the most is that I senseth a plot most foul to turn the Lazarites against us, with Catherine being the first stepping stone on a path to Heaven's destruction!"

The other Archangels felt the blood drain from their faces.

"Impossible..." Uzziel said softly. "We have always treated the Lazarites well! Why woulds't they turn against us?"

"Well? Dost thou truly believe the lives they formerly led on Earth were worse than the lives they now lead in Heaven?" Raphael scoffed. "We hath repeatedly held them back from going 'too far' in their building projects, experimenting with their powers, and so on. I fear that the Archseer mayeth swallowed dreams of certain key individuals within Heaven, perhaps even my own, and in this way, he mayeth uncovered the secrets of what Lazarites can truly accomplish!"

"If my conjecture doth be true, t'would mean a complete collapse of Heaven." Raphael said, his tone simmering with barely concealed rage. "The demons hath already fallen from the position of angelkind's greatest enemy. Now, it appeareth the humans art in contention."

"If... the humans art such a threat..." Gabriel said gingerly, "...then why doth we not reject their offer?"

"Because we CANNOT!" Raphael roared, as he slammed his fist against the side of Michael's coffin. The other Archangels jumped slightly. They couldn't remember the last time they'd seen their eldest brother so angry. "These Trueborn are not to be taken lightly. Especially not that Cat Mask! Camael, thou knoweth more regarding the tapestry of time than any of the rest of us. What doth it mean when a human possesses the power to travel back in time an unlimited number of times?!"

Camael squeezed her eyes shut. She pressed her fingers against her forehead and fruitlessly attempted to massage an incoming headache.

"Such a power... goes against Akasha." Camael said with a grimace. "It shoulds't not exist. Ever since the Great Shattering, I hath lost my ability to peer into the future. The way of Fate hath turneth as opaque as the walls in this cathedral."

"Hath thou ever been able to peer beyond the veil of Fate?" Raphael asked his sister pointedly.

"Indeed... well... nay..." Camael said, opening her eyes to frown deeply. "I... in the past, I was able... but no, I was... never able to see beyond... hmm? Strange. Why hath I never thought of this conundrum before? Surely, verily, I recalleth a time when I coulds't peer into the future to determine... but nay, that hath never actually happened at all? Why doth two memories intermingle within my mind?"

A long silence followed. Raphael stared at the ground, his face contorted into an expression of rage.

"Because... *Cat Mask*." Raphael spat. "Verily, that human hath caused the Great Shattering. This ancient one remembers... thou prophesied t'would come one day... but it did not 'come'... it hath always 'been.'"

Question marks popped up over Uzziel's head. "Hmm? Thou art saying the Great Shattering was destined to someday arrive, yet t'was always here? Brother, thy words make no sense!"

"I am equally mystified." Gabriel chimed in.

"Heh heh heh..." Raphael gurgled in his throat. "Cat Mask. This human frightens me. He went against Akasha's way and somehow shattered the universe. I know not how he did it, only that he was responsible. If he hath truly witnessed an infinite number of

futures, then he musteth observed our many reactions to the coming war. Doubtless, Jessica's words were perfectly tailored to get us to do as Cat Mask wished."

The more Raphael spoke, the graver the other Archangel's expressions became.

"Heaven is no longer safe." Camael muttered. "Our enemy doth be a time traveler who knows precisely what events shalt come to pass. We art being outmaneuvered at every turn..."

"If... if that is true... then what can we do?" Uzziel asked, nibbling her nails worriedly.

"I was taken by surprise." Raphael muttered. "I lack the time needed to contemplate the greater ramifications of today's visit. I must attend to the battle against the demons first, then the rest of these issues afterward."

Uzziel looked at Michael's sleeping body. She glanced at Raphael. "Brother, dost thou intendeth not to awaken Michael? I know thy words were but a deception upon whoever is observing us, but they did make sense to me..."

"Perhaps Michael mayeth possess insights that could assist us in our time of need?" Gabriel added. It seemed he wished to speak to Michael again as well.

But Raphael held up a palm to silence them.

"Nay. We mustn't awaken Michael needlessly. He, and all the rest of us, must recuperate within our rings for a long period before we can permanently reawaken. Every instance when I hath awakened him temporarily in the past, I hath also delayed his return. Tis' better to allow him to sleep as much as possible, restoring his soul's energy over time. When he rises naturally, he shalt be capable of conversing with all of us at will."

"Oh... I see." Uzziel said, deflating a little. Michael had always been her second favorite sibling, after Samael. Not being able to talk to him for thousands of years had deeply saddened her, just as the death of Samael had. But she didn't have any good arguments to rebuke her eldest brother. She certainly didn't want to accidentally harm Michael just to soothe her own pangs of longing.

Raphael managed to calm himself down and cool his anger, but still, rage simmered below the surface.

"Catherine can no longer be trusted." Raphael said gloomily. "All those years spent training her hath gone to waste. She was to become a Valkyrie in the vein of her

predecessor, but now we cannot make her a figurehead for the Lazarites, knowing she hath become a mole in our midst."

"Perhaps we can find a replacement?" Gabriel suggested.

"None who are similarly worthy exist, and training a new Lazarite shalt prove troublesome." Raphael muttered. "The revelation that Catherine was Joan's sister would have made her appear divinely mandated for the position, but no other Lazarites possess similar clout. The ones who mayest are all former world leaders, with excessive political baggage that would drag them down in the eyes of their peers."

"Such matters needs't wait until later." Camael said dismissively. "Let us focus on the coming battle. Brother, I fear that the demons mayeth a different objective beyond simply killing thee."

Raphael fell silent. His face changed expressions several times. It seemed he was harboring similar thoughts.

"The Lazarus Tower..." Raphael muttered.

"Aye." Camael said. "We hath kept the secret of Valac's Lantern to ourselves all these years. Never hath we spoken of its existence to anyone, not even King Zeus. All along, we believed the demons had not learned of the truth behind the Lazarus Tower."

"Outwardly, we hath already declared that the Tower alloweth the Lazarites to reform from deceased humans." Uzziel said. "Tis' not unthinkable to me that the demons hath realized destroying the Tower shalt cripple our future military strength."

"This is indeed the most likely possibility." Raphael grumbled. "If the demons doth not truly wish to kill one or more of the Archangels, then destroying the Tower shalt be their next most likely tactic."

"Assuming the demons dids't learn of the Lantern, woulds't stealing it bring them any benefit?" Camael questioned.

"Unlikely. We tied Michael's power to the Lantern. That is how we were able to revive humans as Lazarites." Raphael replied. "Thus, the demons cannot use it to create their own 'Lazarites'. The Lantern shalt grant them no tactical advantage. Destroying it is the only way in which they mayeth benefit."

"Then we needeth reinforce the defenses around the Lazarus Tower." Camael concluded. "This is a matter the Titans can assist us with. They art more than powerful

enough to assist, and no ground army shalt be able to push past an enraged Titan King. Zeus alone is ten times the warrior he was during the Ancient Era, to say nothing of his progeny."

Raphael thought of Heaven's layout. The Lazarus Tower was extremely conspicuous. It was positioned in one of the centermost areas, far from the Sinai portal, but close enough that a wall of determined Demon Emperors might be able to rush it down and destroy it. It was hundreds of meters tall, and could be seen from nearly anywhere in Heaven. A glowing gem atop the tower served as a beacon, similar to the North Star when looking up at Earth's night sky.

In truth, destroying the Tower wouldn't accomplish anything. Camael had built the Tower, and she could rebuild it again. The issue was the Lantern itself. If the demons knew of the Lantern's existence, then they could destroy it, and that would permanently end the rebirth cycle of Lazarites.

Raphael would be quite annoyed if the Tower were destroyed, but within a year or two, Camael would have rebuilt it, and the flow of Lazarites would continue. It was protecting the Lantern that was his top priority... as well as hiding its existence.

"Why not simply remove the Lantern?" Gabriel questioned. "One of us could carry it a while."

"The Lantern's aura hath been suppressed by the formations Camael placed in its storage chamber, deep below the Tower." Raphael said, shaking his head. "If we were to extract it, every demon Grunt within a thousand kilometers woulds't sense its presence, along with the lesser Angels, and the Titans to boot. After Michael empowered the Lantern, its might hath grown considerably."

"If we remove the Lantern, the formations will break down." Camael added. "In the end, I woulds't need to rebuild the Tower from scratch all over again, the same as if the demons destroyed the Tower."

"Better to suffer a short setback than to risk losing everything." Gabriel said.

Once again, all four Archangels fell silent. A war raged inside Raphael's mind.

He couldn't think of any methods the demons would use to steal the Lantern and turn it into their own demon-Lazarite resurrection machine. The Lantern's other uses were not great in his eyes, and certainly not worth starting a war over.

Thus, destroying the Lantern, destroying the Tower, or killing one or more Archangels seemed the most obvious goal of this demon attack. Everything had started when the demons learned of the two Trueborn, so this attack must be borne of desperation, lacking in prep time.

Raphael *could* remove the Lantern and take it somewhere else. If he did, the Titans would sense its presence, and many questions would be asked. Troublesome questions...

The Archangel of Wisdom had no idea if the humans knew of the Lantern. Given the Archseer's ability to 'eat dreams', perhaps he had learned of the Lantern at some point? Perhaps Cat Mask had uncovered its existence in a future timeline?

But then again, maybe Jessica had lied to the Archangels, and the stated powers of both Trueborn were lies! Maybe there was no time traveler and there was no Dream Eater. If so, then Raphael would be making a terrible mistake if he started assuming all his secrets had been spilled!

This left him at a crossroads. He had to make a decision, and that decision had ramifications so dire it nearly took his breath away.

"We... must gamble." Raphael eventually concluded. "Leave the Lantern in place. Guard the Tower. Pray our enemies believe the Tower itself is the source of the Lazarites, pray that destroying the Tower is their goal. If so, then the Lantern shalt remain hidden underground, the Titans will not learn of it, and we can rebuild at a future date."

"Gambling is not thy usual way of doing things." Camael observed, giving her eldest brother a side-glance of disapproval. "I am fine with rebuilding the Tower from scratch. T'would be safer to extract the Lantern."

"Doing so would guarantee our enemies and allies learn of its existence." Raphael said, holding up his palm. "I shalt not brook any further discussion on the matter. The Lantern is one of Heaven's greatest secrets. We must not simply assume all our enemies hath become mind-reading, future-predicting monstrosities."

"I... disagree with thy decision." Camael said, closing her eyes and looking away. "But I shalt abide by it."

"As shalt I." Gabriel said with a nod.

"And I as well." Uzziel concluded.

Like this, the Archangels reached a consensus. Raphael instructed them to keep all sensitive discussions limited to ring-dialogues between one another.

Then, he broke the spell and returned them to reality.

War was coming.

Raphael was far less certain now of what the outcome would be than he was earlier that morning…

Part 771: Rag Doll

January 29th, 2021. Inside Aevum.

For every hour that passed on Earth, a little over 15 days passed inside Aevum. This meant that in the time that someone on Earth had finished watching the morning news, someone in Aevum could have lived through two entire work weeks with change to spare.

Jason Hiro was able to watch the demons slowly rally their forces, construct underground tunnels and defenses around Sinai, and portal Warpers over to surround the mountain. He knew the clock was ticking, and the demons' attack was imminent.

Even so, Jason found himself trying to herd a group of teenagers around during one of the most hormonal parts of their lives. Jerome was extremely diligent in his training, and Jason set out to build a specialized chamber that would rapidly increase Jerome's strength. Despite this, Jerome constantly skedaddled off to fool around with his girlfriend, wasting time in Jason's eyes that he could spend training for the upcoming war.

Unlike Jerome, Marco seemed to suffer from extreme ADHD and utterly lacked interest in messing around with his power. More accurately, he feared his power, all because of his past trauma with killing a dog that had attacked him. No matter how Jason tried to explain things to Marco, it seemed he just wasn't mentally able to wrap his head around fighting in a war.

Sasha surprised Jason the most. Once she learned that her power had more practical uses, she started using it constantly, even to the point of draining all her energy and passing out wherever she was standing or sitting. Several times, the other teenagers had found Sasha comatose on the floor drooling uncontrollably due to her mana levels being depleted below zero.

Jason should have been worried to see her overexert herself and pleased that she was being so diligent, but unfortunately, Sasha spent most of her time using her powers to design *clothes*. She was an aspiring fashion designer, and she loved to change the colors of outfits, alter the fabric and material, and do other such things. Her interest in anything warfare or combat related was just as pitiful as Marco's.

Then there was Nadia. No longer needing to fear overusing her powers and ruining her body, Nadia dove into books, devoured the internet, and rapidly amassed a country's worth of information at a speed Jason could barely fathom. Her ability, Total Comprehension, made it extremely easy for her to not only consume and learn new information, but to understand it as well.

The truly tricky part of her abilities was converting existing knowledge into new innovations. Someone could be a great learner, even a great teacher, but still end up a poor innovator. Luckily, Nadia did not have that issue. She was already showing signs of becoming an inventor superior to the Phoebe Jason knew in the future. The wife he'd lost.

In addition to all of them, there was Brian Bozzard. A flame manipulator Lowborn, he also lacked a killer instinct and drive to fight in battle. However, perhaps because of his wealthy upbringing and years of home tutoring, he was much more mature than the others his age. He diligently practiced manipulating his flames as Jason asked, but unlike a certain other flame manipulator Jason had known in the future, Brian was a lot weaker, and not terribly brilliant when it came to thinking up novel uses for his power.

Jason sat inside his Sanctum, hidden within a tiny pocket of Aevum, and sighed. The only teenager who was fully prepared to go to war was his daughter. Daisy had seen a future far worse than anything the other teenagers could dream up in their worst nightmares. Daisy had only been six years old when the demons attacked Hero City, the Fortress of Retribution. She had been outwardly fearless due to unexpected factors related to her young heroic awakening, but that didn't mean she hadn't suffered mental traumas from what she saw.

Then she went back in time and ended up captured, experimented on, and treated like an animal for at least two long years. It broke Jason's heart thinking of what she had gone through. No child should have to go through what she did, and as a father, Jason could intuitively tell it had hardened her in many ways, visible and invisible.

Jason lowered his head. He stared at the floor silently.

It wasn't that the teenagers in Aevum were lazy, but that he was just as broken as his daughter. What teenager would truly dream of going out and fighting demons, killing them, feeling their blood coat their faces and hands, and then doing it again and again for years to come?

Jason felt as if he had become unrecognizable over the years. When he first got his powers, he used them to laze around. He used them to make himself look big and macho and tough. He used his powers to make life easier for himself. He didn't take the demon threat seriously, opting to let Neil and Hope deal with the military side of things. Jason played the role of a king, but he was nothing more than a spoiled prince.

It took terrible tragedies and losses to reshape him into the man he was now. Somewhere along the way, he had changed, just like his daughter. She was ready to fight. She was ready for war, just like him. Because she was broken. And so was he.

Jason knew it in his heart. It wasn't natural, constantly planning and strategizing, preparing for a future fight. Humans liked being lazy, watching TV, playing games, cooking food, having sex. Jason liked it too... presumably. But somewhere along the way, he'd holed himself up in Chrona for a few hundred years and spent very little time with his wife. That was why she had died.

Phoebe Hiro died because Jason took the lessons of the past so seriously that he threw away his future. Now he wasn't sure what he had to live for, beyond spending a bit of time with his little girl, and his father.

"What am I even doing." Jason muttered to himself.

It wasn't a question, but a statement. He knew what he was doing. The same thing he'd done on the day Phoebe died. Planning and preparing for a war among wars. An unending war. Once the battle for Sinai began, it would set into motion a series of events that would continue out into the inestimable future.

If the demons won, would they be satisfied with their victory and lay back on luxurious couches in contentment?

If the demons lost, would they simply return to their burrows and give up, knowing any further conflict was pointless?

The answer to both questions was obviously 'no'. Whatever the outcome, there would be another war in the future, and another after that, and still another. Even if the angels and demons were wiped out, there were still the Volgrim, and the entire universe outside the Milky Way.

Even if humans rose up and dominated the entire universe, they would just turn on themselves.

Jason closed his eyes.

Was this the truth? Maybe his earlier thoughts were wrong. Maybe it wasn't human nature to crave peace and be lazy. Maybe war was actually their drive. Maybe war was something innate to the universe. Maybe conflict was, itself, a fundamental building block of life. All energy came from somewhere. Even cells reproduced by devouring the ambient energy within their surroundings. To gain something, one must first consume something.

Jason stood up. He wandered around inside his silent Sanctum. He stared at the walls, many of which had pictures of his deceased wife. He had created them with his Wordsmithing. They were photo-realistic to the point he almost felt he could kiss her lips.

But he didn't deserve that. How could he think of his own pangs of longing when he had failed her, letting her die in the end?

Jason averted his eyes. He blinked heavily, then paused as he felt a signal lightly tap his brain.

[Dad?]

It was Daisy's voice. He'd given her a small artifact she could use to communicate with him telepathically from anywhere, not dissimilar to one he'd given Phoebe.

Jason didn't reply. Instead, he uttered a Word of Power and vanished from the spot, appearing in his daughter's bedroom inside the dormitories. When he appeared, he found Daisy sitting on her bed, looking directly at him as if she had anticipated his exact arrival point.

"What's up, sweetheart?" Jason asked, smiling at her with tired eyes.

Daisy opened her mouth to say something, but then she paused and squinted at him.

"Is that... you?" Daisy asked.

"Yes? Of course it's me. What do you mean?" Jason asked.

"Not one of your robo-clones?" Daisy asked.

"No. This is the real me..." Jason said slowly. "What's the matter? Is something bothering you?"

Daisy seemed hesitant. "It's just... I can never tell if it's you I'm talking to or one of your copies. It really bothers me, Dad."

"Oh. Sorry I've been making you feel that way." Jason said seriously. "But sweetie, don't you think... you're overblowing it a little bit? My copies are directly connected to my brain. I can see through their eyes, hear what they hear, experience the lives they live. It's like I'm in six places at once. If one of them is talking to you, it's exactly the same as right now, when I'm talking to you."

"Maybe it feels that way to you, but it doesn't feel that way to me." Daisy said, turning her head away. "You don't get it, Dad. I'm a telepath. Though I work hard to not use my abilities on everyone, I always have a surface level sense of what they're feeling, what they're thinking. But not with you."

She continued. "At first, I did have the ability to read your thoughts. Back when we met for the first time in the cabin. You felt like a real person. I felt your pain... I experienced what it must have felt like when you lost Mom. But then you regained your memories, built Aevum, and returned in a robotic body. Now your clones feel like lifeless pieces of metal to me, and your main body feels exactly the same. You don't feel like a real human anymore. It really bothers me."

Jason stared at his daughter's side profile for a moment. A sensation of guilt hung over him. He felt the air in the room grow a little heavier.

After a few seconds, Jason stepped over and sat beside his daughter. He wrapped an arm around her shoulder and gave her a reassuring squeeze.

"I'm sorry, honey. I didn't know you were feeling that way. You know why I have to do this though, right? Our enemies aren't just the demons, but the angels too, and soon the Volgrim. The Volgrim Empire has an entire subspecies that specializes in telepathy. The very thing you find alienating about me is the same thing I'm using to protect myself, protect Aevum, and protect *you*. I can't take a risk and allow you to read my mind, because a hole in my defenses would allow *any* telepath to do that."

"Besides," Jason added, "other people don't have telepathy, and they do just fine interacting with me and my clones. I'm not saying this is a 'you' problem, but don't you think relying on your telepathy to get close to other people is, in itself, a little alienating? What if you meet a guy in the future and he learns you're a telepath, then he starts to distrust you?"

Daisy scowled. "I already know that's a problem, Dad. I hadn't disclosed my telepathy to anyone prior to coming to Aevum, but I've always known that telling people would

probably scare them away. That's *why* I didn't. Even Sasha and the rest were weirded out at first. I think the only reason they didn't ultimately pull away is because they had their own secret powers they were hiding, so they were just as focused on themselves as thinking about me, and the *implications* of me."

Jason lowered his gaze to the ground. He fell deep into thought.

This was not a problem he could easily solve. He could offer to make a tool of some sort that naturally inhibited his daughter's telepathy, completely suppressed it, or entirely turned it off. Doing so would be pretty easy, especially for the current him.

But would that be the right thing to do? Of course not. For Daisy, telepathy was completely natural. She'd been reading minds since she was a child. It was just another sense to her, like hearing and vision. Removing it would be like cutting off her ears. She would feel vulnerable and limited, having lost one of the methods she used to read the world around her.

Of course, since other humans *didn't* have telepathy, it not only gave her an unfair advantage when interacting with them, it meant their usually private thoughts were actually out in the open before her eyes. She could easily tell when someone was lying to her, pretending to be nice, hiding their real intentions, and other such things. Even something innocuous, like a white lie about how pretty her outfit looked, so as to not be rude, was still something she could see as plainly as if they had said it out loud.

Thus, if someone were to learn of Daisy's telepathy, they would almost assuredly feel violated. They might feel as though their secret, innermost thoughts and desires had been laid bare by her. It was a form of mind-rape, one that would deservedly cause them to pull away.

Daisy knew this, and that was why she didn't tell anyone. But just because nobody knew, that didn't mean what she was doing was okay.

If Jason couldn't even offer to disable Daisy's ability to help her fit in, then what was the alternative? Maybe he could turn other people into telepaths? Turn the entirety of humanity telepathic? But if everyone was reading everyone else's thoughts, then what would happen to private thoughts? Private fantasies? Could such an honest society function well?

The other option was something involving a more limited form of telepathy. Perhaps something akin to 'consensual telepathy' only? People couldn't read the thoughts of

others willy-nilly, but they could project their thoughts into the minds of others if allowed, and guard their innermost thoughts even from powerful telepaths like Daisy.

But in the end, wouldn't that mostly be the same as living in a society of non-telepaths?? Jason was bewildered. If this was the solution he used, then he'd basically just turned people's brains into a social media page, advertising their outermost thoughts while hiding their real selves. That clearly wasn't preferable.

And, in the end, the real issue at the current moment in time wasn't any of this philosophical mumbo-jumbo. It was that his daughter was used to using her telepathy to get a read on people, but she couldn't use it on her own father, making him feel alien to her.

Jason didn't mind opening up his private thoughts to his daughter. She would see shameful things inside his head. Sad things. Things that, in all honesty, he'd prefer she didn't see, but as long as it was for his beautiful little girl's sake, he'd be more than happy to make that sacrifice.

The problem was, Jason wasn't lying when he said a gap opened for her would be a gap other telepaths could use. He couldn't simply open his mind up to her and her alone. It would leave him vulnerable to the Psions, along with any potential telepaths among the demons and angels.

Come to think of it...

"The Psions..." Jason muttered.

"Huh?" Daisy asked. "What... what about them?"

Naturally, all these musings in Jason's head had been hidden from Daisy, so she had no idea why his train of thought had shifted so abruptly.

"Oh, nothing, it's just... I was thinking about the Psions, and telepathy." Jason said. "Now that I think about it, they're a society of mind-readers entirely lacking mouths. They only communicate through thought. I wonder how a society of telepaths would function. I've... never really *thought* about it. I knew they were telepathic, and I took measures to protect myself and others, but I just had so much on my plate I never put a lot of time into the philosophy of a telepathic society."

Jason took a minute to detail his inner thoughts to Daisy, explaining to her why he'd thought of offering to inhibit or remove her telepathy, then why he'd thought of elevating

humans to become telepathic, and how that ultimately led to pondering the society the Psions had built.

"Humans live and breathe a steady diet of lies." Daisy said, after her father had finished explaining his inner thoughts. "The reason you don't think humanity becoming telepaths would be a good idea is because in your eyes, it's normal to conceal your private inner thoughts from others. That's how you're able to scheme and plan for the future. It's how you're able to fantasize and dream about possibilities others might think are weird, or gross, or even abhorrent. And everyone around you is doing the same thing, all the time, every day."

"So," Daisy continued, "that makes you think that if everyone could read everyone else's minds, then it would either end up putting us back in the same place, or it would cause a catastrophic breakdown in trust."

Jason nodded. "You read my mind. Metaphorically speaking."

Jason smiled at Daisy, but his little joke didn't get a smile back from her. Instead, she gave him a deeply serious look.

"You don't get it, Dad. If you want, you *can* read minds. You merely *use* telepathy. I imagine you don't do it often, because you feel it's a violation of other people's privacy. And that is true... but it also means you're not a 'real' telepath. You haven't considered the benefits of a telepathic society."

"What benefits?" Jason asked. He was genuinely curious, and it seemed his daughter had put a lot of thought into this.

"Dad..." Daisy said quietly. "When I was nine years old, shortly after Uncle Vasily had adopted me, he let me adopt a puppy. I named the dog Ragdoll, because she was a Basset Hound with these cute floppy ears, curly hair, and she loved to roll around in the grass."

"Okay." Jason said, squinting at his daughter. He wondered why she'd changed the conversation so abruptly. "Sounds like a cute dog."

"When I was fifteen years old, just a few years ago, Ragdoll ran out into the street, right into incoming traffic." Daisy said, her expression unchanging. "She was hit by a truck. She died instantly. It destroyed me for months."

"Oh... baby." Jason said, feeling his heart deflate. He didn't expect his daughter's story to take such a turn, so quickly.

Jason started to lean toward Daisy, to kiss her forehead, to reassure her, but Daisy pulled away. Her expression was the same as before.

"I'm not done, Dad." She said firmly. "It devastated me. Words can't describe how I felt. I could tell you that I cried for weeks. I could tell you that everywhere I went in the house, I saw Ragdoll in the corner of rooms where she used to roll around. I saw Ragdoll barking out in the yard. I could even tell you that I've never truly gotten over her death, and the guilt of not reacting quickly enough, especially with all *my* abilities, has only intensified over time."

Jason cocked his head slightly. It really hurt to hear this story from Daisy, but... where was she going with all this?

Daisy took a long, deep breath. She looked away.

"Dad, lower your mental defenses for a moment. Let me into your head."

The Wordsmith hesitated. After everything he'd told her before, she should know why he was so hesitant about making his thoughts vulnerable. It would also cause his clones in Realspace to become vulnerable to telepathic intrusion, too.

"It's only for a minute or two." Daisy said quietly. "Just do it, Dad. For me."

His daughter wasn't asking. She was giving him an order.

As a father, Jason felt like he owed Daisy a lot. He decided, at least this once, to do as she asked.

"**Normalize.**" Jason said, targeting only his mental defenses.

In an instant, his psychic shield, impenetrable even to Cosmic Psions, vanished. His thoughts became freely available for Daisy to peruse.

But Daisy didn't try to read his mind. That wasn't her intention. Instead, she turned to look at him.

An instant later, her memories came flooding in.

It was like a dam had burst, a dam holding back a river of emotions.

Jason was there, age nine. He adopted little Ragdoll. He felt joy at seeing the cute little dog rolling in the grass. He cleaned up her fur, picked up her poop, scolded her when she peed on the carpet, but never held it against her.

Jason played with the dog. He took her to the park. He laughed when she chased away a dog much bigger than her with her little yappy barks. He felt a deep, deep connection to her, as if she were really his dog.

Sometimes, Jason sat at the computer with Ragdoll in his lap. The little Basset Hound would fall asleep with her nose buried in his belly, curled up in a ball. She was a playful dog, yes, but also a lap dog with a comforting presence.

Jason was there when Ragdoll died. He didn't even see it coming. She bolted when his attention was elsewhere. He screamed in horror when he saw what she was doing. He was so caught off-guard that his telekinesis momentarily faltered. He failed to use his powers, something he'd instinctively trained since childhood. She ran out in front of the truck, and the sound of the impact struck him like a baseball bat to his face.

Thump. Crunch.

The dog didn't even let out a yip or a yelp. She died instantly. His healing powers couldn't revive her. He couldn't save her.

Jason stumbled toward the dead dog, his mind in a fog. The truck had stopped a little ways up the road. A balding Russian man with a bulging belly hopped out and speed-walked over. He had a hobble in his leg, and wore a dirty pair of jeans along with a t-shirt that didn't quite fit.

"Ahh, what you doing?" The man shouted angrily. "Letting your dog run into street? Look at this mess! Stupid girl! Why do kids not train dog properly, now I have blood on my hands! Fucking hell, idiot!"

The despair in Jason's eyes grew. Not only had his beloved Ragdoll just been killed, but this piece of shit had the *guts* to berate him, as if it was his fault? Who gave him the nerve. He had no idea who he was messing with.

Jason felt his rage and fury build. Such a worthless man, not even repentant, not even sorry for what he'd done. Sure, it hadn't been his fault. He had no way of slowing down in time. But to not even be a *little* sorry?

People like him shouldn't exist in the world.

That was why Jason suddenly lashed out with his telekinesis, grabbed onto the man's body, and let out an unintelligible scream of rage before shattering all his internal organs and compressing his existence into a speck of blood and bone.

In Jason's rage, he brutally murdered the man, giving vent to his own hatred, his own self-loathing, his own despair. He killed that man to avenge his dog, to make himself feel better, and to...

...Jason didn't kill the man. Neither did Daisy. Instead, this thought of brutally murdering the bastard who'd killed Ragdoll came and went. It was a momentary impulse, an explosive desire that she nearly acted on, but she didn't. Instead, Daisy simply stood there, frozen, staring at the body of her dog, splattered on the pavement. The man berated her for a minute, then turned, stormed away, and got back in his truck. He drove off, leaving a trail of blood in his wake.

Jason knelt down next to Ragdoll. He sobbed. He couldn't stop crying. The minutes turned into hours, and then days, and then weeks.

Jason buried Ragdoll out back, near her doghouse. He made a large gravestone, and even used his powers to chisel an image of Ragdoll onto the stone.

Physically, Jason moved on. But mentally, a part of him died that day. A part of his childhood innocence. It gave birth to a rage he couldn't control. It gave birth to feelings of inadequacy, guilt, and self loathing.

Jason met with his friends. Sasha, Marco, and Nadia. They offered words of comfort. They were sad about the death of his dog. They were empathetic. They were understanding.

But a few weeks passed. Jason's friends moved on. They didn't *forget* about Ragdoll's death, but they clearly didn't put a thousandth the thought into her death as Jason did. He was still dealing with the pain. The sadness. The loss. The anger.

He should have been faster. He should have reacted faster. He should have pulled the dog back, or thrown the truck aside. He should have killed that bastard of a driver. No, it was good he didn't. Even if the driver was a bastard, it wasn't his fault the dog died. But still, that man deserved to die! It was good that Jason hadn't killed him. He just wished he had.

Years passed. The pain faded over time. But it would sometimes come rushing back, ten times more intense than before, made even worse because of the time spent not feeling guilt, when he'd almost forgotten about Ragdoll. His fading guilt over any period of time made the return of the guilt so much worse when it struck again. How *dare* he not

feel guilty about his failure? He'd failed Ragdoll. What right did he have to smile and be happy? He was a failure of a man.

* * *

Daisy's memory of Ragdoll hit Jason hard. When the memory stopped playing, Jason found that he was sobbing uncontrollably, and he didn't know when he'd started. His chest heaved over and over. It ached with pain.

All this time, Jason realized, he'd thought Daisy couldn't understand what it meant for him to lose Phoebe. He'd been shielding her from his thoughts. He'd been keeping himself closed off.

But he was wrong. Daisy knew. Her loss might not be exactly the same as his, but that didn't mean it was any less painful.

This was what it meant to be a telepath. It meant to share concepts, thoughts, memories, in their purest, rawest form. Words could only take someone so far. They could never truly feel what the other person had felt. They could only experience a small sliver of that person's loss, or gain.

This was a hint of what a society of telepaths could experience. It was the reason Daisy felt so alienated by her father's sealed mind. She wanted to experience his pain and happiness. She wanted him to experience hers.

As for the concerns of privacy, there was no reason a telepath couldn't keep certain thoughts and feelings private. That was always an option. But what they did decide to share, they would share in the rawest, purest form. It allowed for a level of intimacy unmatched by mere words and body language.

"Oh, baby girl... I... I get it now." Jason said, still heaving terrible sobs of loss. "Ragdoll... Phoebe... they might... might be dead... but they exist within us. Keeping those... those feelings locked down... hic... it's not okay. We have to be more open."

Daisy hugged her father tightly. She pushed her head into his chest, tears falling down her face onto his shirt.

Jason couldn't just turn all of humanity into telepaths. It wasn't a viable option, certainly not in the short term. But sharing more of himself with his little girl? That was something he now wanted to do.

It was now that he understood why she was the way she was. It was no wonder she seemed so... bloodthirsty. So hungry and eager for action. It wasn't only because of what happened when she was a small child, but all her cumulative life experiences.

Daisy had lost her dog, someone she loved more than life itself. The guilt had forged her determination into something similar to Jason's. She wanted to be better, and never to fail others again.

How could he tell her 'no' now, knowing all this?

"Dad... let's just stay like this... for a while." Daisy whispered.

Jason had a lot of other work he needed to do. His duties were never-ending. Even now, he was micro-managing his clones in Realspace.

But...

"Sure, honey." Jason said, kissing the top of his daughter's head.

He couldn't say no to his little girl.

Part 772: Faceless

January 29th, 2021. Inside Aevum.

Jason was a busy man these days. Even so, he didn't want to give up a chance to spend time with his daughter. He stayed with her, hugging and comforting her for thirty long minutes. The two of them idly chatted about this and that. But eventually, the needs of reality started to press on him.

"Dad..." Daisy mumbled. "When are you going to change back?"

Jason pulled away and gave her a weird look. "Change back?"

"Yeah. To the way you're supposed to look." Daisy said. "I don't like my dad looking the same age as me. Just use your magic to make yourself all big and strong again, like I remember when I was a kid."

Jason looked at her for several long seconds.

"I... I don't think that's going to happen, honey."

"What? Why not??" Daisy asked in bewilderment. "You can totally use your Wordsmithing to do it!"

"It's not that I can't, but that I shouldn't." Jason said, averting his eyes. "That wasn't who I really was. I guess you were too little to know this, but what you see now is how I should have looked. This is my normal self. When I first obtained my magic, I used it to turn myself into this good-looking beefcake. Muscles, pearly white teeth, a smoothed face, even a slick hairstyle."

He continued. "I did that for a lot of reasons, honey. But the main reason? Vanity. I didn't want to look like a wimp anymore. I wanted to be big, strong, and cool. I wanted to look like a god among men."

Daisy gazed at her father's side profile. "Well... when you put it like that, it does seem a *little* childish. But so what? What's wrong with changing yourself to look better? Most people would kill to be able to do that. Hell, *I* would, and I'm already pretty good looking myself!"

Jason frowned. He looked at his daughter and shook his head.

"I can already feel the vanity in your voice, and you're right, sweetie. You're a gorgeous girl. A ten out of ten in my eyes. But what you just said really cuts to the core of the problem. I made myself into something I wasn't. Why? To get other people to admire me, to make myself feel better, and so on. It was all for vanity and... maybe I'm overthinking it, but I now feel that there's just something innately *wrong* with that. I can't put it into words."

Daisy looked like she wanted to argue with her father, but she stayed silent when she saw a flicker in his eyes.

"You know." Jason said quietly. "Before I met your mother... there was another woman I fell in love with. Her name was Amelia... the Black Witch. She told me something once and... I ignored it at the time, but it percolated in my mind, and it's been coming up in my thoughts a lot recently."

"What was that?" Daisy asked.

"She told me she liked me just the way I was." Jason answered. "She liked my authentic self... not my big-buff-guy persona. It struck a nerve in me at the time, but it wasn't until I returned to the past and saw my reflection in the mirror that I seriously dwelt on her words."

Jason looked at the wall across from Daisy's bed. "I changed what I looked like because I was ashamed of who I was... what I looked like. The truth is, I didn't love myself. I didn't respect myself. I wanted to obtain love and affection at any cost, even if it meant becoming someone I was not."

"I see." Daisy said, lowering her eyes. "That... I think I get it."

Jason's expression brightened. "But that's the thing, sweetheart. I don't know if I love myself more than I did before, but I certainly respect myself a bit more. Your old man is dealing with... problems. But I know what I can do, I know who I am, and I know what I want to be. The failures of my past are informing the man I want to become. So I don't know if I should change myself back into Buff Jason, any more than you should put on makeup and turn yourself into some famous movie star actress."

Daisy pondered her father's words seriously. "So that's the reason you're going to remain in your youthful appearance?"

"Oh, NO, haha. That's not the only reason!" Jason laughed. "I have an even better reason than all of that!"

Daisy blinked. She squinted at her father's playful expression. "Huh? Like what?"

"Project Great Deceiver!" Jason said, shoving his thumb into his chest. "It's a lot easier to fool the demons and angels into thinking I'm a weak nobody if I look like a scrawny teenager. They won't take me seriously, making it a lot easier for me to prep for the future! Besides, if I suddenly strolled into the middle of their armies looking like a gigachad while kicking 10,000 demonic asses, don't you think they'd realize my powers aren't what I said?"

"Oh... yeah. Good point." Daisy said, rolling her eyes. Now that Jason mentioned it, that was a pretty damn good reason to stay as he was. "Gotta keep them thinking you're a 'dream eater'."

"Exactly, sweetie." Jason said, as he leaned over and kissed Daisy's forehead lovingly. "Now, if you'll excuse me, I do need to be going."

"Wait, dad." Daisy said, causing him to pause.

"...Yes?" Jason asked, expecting her to come up with another reason they should keep talking. He didn't really want to go anyway, and his willpower toward Daisy was paper-thin.

"Before you go back to all your important business, can you drop by and say hi to Farrah?" Daisy asked.

"Jerome's girlfriend?" Jason asked. "Uh... I mean... I don't know... don't you think that's a little inappropriate?"

"Dad, come on. It's not like that." Daisy said seriously. "Farrah's been feeling really down lately, and she won't tell anybody why. I'm just hoping you can get her to open up. I don't know her very well, and the other girls can't get her to open up either."

Jason hemmed and hawed for a few moments, but ultimately agreed. He hadn't really talked to Farrah Lapis all that much, and if it was just a quick wellness check, it couldn't hurt.

Jason kissed his daughter's forehead again, then quickly skedaddled, leaving her in her room.

The Wordsmith reappeared atop a small outcropping near the top of the Nexus Spire. For a brief minute, Jason gazed down upon the world he had created. A sense of overwhelming satisfaction swallowed him as he beheld the realm he had created.

Superior to Volgarius. Better than Heaven. More fearsome than Raphael's false Cosmic Realm or Satan's Hell. Jason had never seen such a realm as terrifying in its possibilities as Aevum was. The people living there, including his own daughter, had absolutely no idea just what Jason truly hoped to accomplish.

Aevum was not merely a secretive realm for developing weapons and technology. It was the future stronghold of humanity, and eventually, the Milky Way itself.

Hundreds, thousands, even millions of years in the future, the name of Aevum would send a chill down the spine of anyone who opposed it. The might of Humanity would continuously grow over time, eventually reaching a level that would force those who stood against humanity to bow their heads and bend their knees. If they did not, their heads would fall from their shoulders.

It was a grandiose vision. It was a concept that would not bear fruit for a long, long time. What meager advantages it gave Jason now were minuscule in comparison to the future gains.

Jason had to protect Aevum in its infancy. If the Psions uncovered its hiding place, Dosena would likely lash out and eradicate it after realizing the threat it represented to the Volgrim Empire.

The good news was, Jason had foreseen the dangers of the future. He had placed Aevum near the galactic Core explicitly to hide it from the gaze of the Cosmics among the Volgrim Empire. Even if it emanated a fearsome magical signature, they would have difficulty locating it due to the cosmic energy radiated by thousands of nearby stars.

"I must be very careful." Jason muttered to himself. "One slip-up and I could reveal Aevum's existence to the wrong people."

Aevum was already capable of sustaining several tens of thousands of people. But could Jason risk bringing them here? Not at all. He was already taking a huge risk bringing the children of the Illuminati here, as well as Daisy's friends. He didn't know them well. They were probably trustworthy. But what if one of them wasn't?

It would only take one flappy set of lips to damn his greatest construct to the depths of hell.

Jason looked around. He used his Wordsmithing to search for Farrah's mana signature. Even amidst the vibrant leylines of Aevum, Jason was able to sniff her out in a single second.

Farrah was all by herself. She was laying in a field of grass and flowers beside a crystal blue pool Jason had made for recreational swimming. However, since Aevum's population was so small, nobody had really used the pool for such reasons yet, and she wasn't wearing a bathing suit either. It didn't seem she planned to go for a swim.

Jason gazed down upon Farrah, unseen by her. With his vision, he could see every follicle of hair on her head, even from a kilometer above Aevum's surface.

She had a blank expression on her face, but Jason could tell there was a sense of resignation, perhaps even depression there as well. She seemed to have a lot on her mind.

Jason wasn't a 'people person'. He wasn't great at reading the thoughts of others, unless he cheated by using telepathy. But he didn't like doing that, since, as he told Daisy, it was an invasion of privacy and trust.

Thus, while he had hundreds of lived years to learn how to 'read' other people, he was still an amateur compared to normal humans who made it their profession, let alone ancient Heroes like Mildred. It didn't help that he'd spent most of his lived life in Chrona, living alongside crocodiles and working by himself. He hadn't spent much time or energy on improving this skill.

Even so, Jason could tell something was on Farrah's mind. Without violating her privacy with telepathy, this much was obvious. He wondered if Daisy had read her mind and determined Jason was the best person to help her. It not only seemed possible, but *likely*.

Jason muttered a Word of Power. He vanished from the top of the Spire and appeared at ground level a few hundred feet from Farrah. He approached her from the front, his hands casually folded behind his back. When he got close enough, Jason raised his voice slightly.

"Oh! Farrah, is that you?"

He feigned surprise and felt a little relieved when Farrah blinked her eyes, lifted her head slightly, and looked down her body toward her toes, where she saw the Archseer approaching from a distance away.

"Jason? M-mister Hiro?" Farrah asked, quickly sitting up and crossing her legs as she watched him approach. "What are you doing here?"

"Oh, I was repairing one of the underground leylines." Jason casually fibbed, gesturing toward the ground. "If these break down, Aevum's operations could grind to a halt. Anyway, I saw you laying there, thought I'd say hi. Why are you over here all by your lonesome?"

Farrah's eyes flickered. She looked to the right, then left, seemingly expecting someone to jump out and throw a bowl of milk all over her as a prank. Obviously, nothing of the sort occurred.

"I was, um... I was just... thinking." Farrah said.

She didn't elaborate.

"Thinking?" Jason asked, as he came to a stop some distance away. He stuck his hands in his pockets. "You feeling okay?"

"Yes. I-I, I, I'm feeling fine..." Farrah said nervously.

Her expression turned gloomy. She lowered her eyes to stare at the ground. She started nervously pulling at the grass, plucking out a strand of grass every so often, seemingly unaware she was even doing it.

"You don't look okay." Jason observed. "Is it something I can help you with? I mean, you don't have to tell me if you don't want. But just remember, I'm hundreds of years old. I'm actually a really old man trapped in my much younger and skinnier body. Maybe I can offer some insights?"

Farrah chuckled. The look on her face eased a little, but she continued to stare at the ground. She wasn't good at maintaining eye contact usually, and because of whatever was on her mind, she was even worse than usual.

"Well... I... I um... I don't know." Farrah mumbled.

Jason waited. He flopped onto his back in the grass, rotating himself so he was laying sideways before her. He donned a pair of sunglasses as he turned his face up toward the tiny artificial sun in Aevum's sky. Then he folded his hands over his belly and waited.

When Farrah didn't say anything after a long minute, Jason decided to speak. "Did Jerome hurt you?"

"What? No!" Farrah exclaimed, a look of horror washing over her face. "No, no, nothing l-like that! Where would you get that idea?!"

Jason turned his head to look at her. "He didn't? But you look so sad. I just thought..."

"Jerome would never hurt me." Farrah said. Even despite this, her expression darkened. "Not deliberately."

The gears turned in Jason's head. He struggled to think of what could be causing her bad mood, but he just couldn't place it. Unfortunately, Jason was not Daisy, and he was not Unarin. The latter would have probably deduced what was bothering Farrah within ten seconds and came up with fifteen solutions to her dilemma, but Jason was... a bit slower.

"So... Jerome wouldn't hurt you deliberately." Jason said slowly. "But... maybe accidentally? Has he grown too strong, to the point he did something that scared you?"

A long sigh escaped from Farrah's lips. She exhaled with her whole body, a look of exhaustion coming over her face.

"It wasn't his fault." Farrah finally said, after internally debating whether she should say anything at all. "It's not even because of him in the f-first place... n-not really. It's... it's everyone around here. Everyone..."

Jason raised an eyebrow. Farrah still wasn't looking at him. "Maybe I'm duller than I thought. I still don't quite get it. Have all the people here hurt you in some way?"

"It's... it's my power!" Farrah finally snapped. Her eyes twitched, and she looked like she was on the verge of tears. "You- you brought me here, along with all these other incredible people, but why?! What was the point? I'm just useless, dead weight! My power is worthless! I watch as everyone else g-gets a-all strong, and cool, and they do awesome things... but I'm stuck here with the same useless, crappy power as before!"

Jason started to open his mouth, but the more Farrah talked, the more her emotions started bursting out, as if she couldn't stop them herself.

"A-and then Jerome comes home every day, b-bragging to me about how much stronger he's gotten, and it just makes me feel *miserable* because what do I have anyway?

I can change my *face*? Wow! What a great trick! The amazing Farrah, cornerstone o-of the superhero league! She can make herself look like other, better people! What a joke!"

Jason sat up. By this point, even he could clearly see the problem. "That's what's eating you up? You think your power is bad?"

"Of course it is!" Farrah exclaimed. "But I know what you'll say. You'll say *at least I have a power*. I still have something that 99.99% of other humans don't! Except what does it matter, because we live in a world of angels and demons, and there's even a demon who can do what I do but way better! THAT'S what's bothering me! I just have some useless knockoff power..."

Jason's expression turned serious. He lowered his eyes and stayed silent for a moment, thinking about all his interactions with Farrah.

In truth, he understood she was right. He could offer her some words of comfort, but the truth was that all this time, he hadn't even really thought of her as her own person. She was always just 'Jerome's girlfriend' in his mind. He had disregarded her power and not thought about her situation at all. Here she was, living among all these amazing people, obviously disregarded by them, and feeling stuck and trapped inside Aevum, becoming little more than an attachment to the 'real' Hero, Jerome.

How miserable would that situation be? If she had accomplishments of her own, she could at least stand proudly with self confidence to match. But stuck amidst all these extraordinary people, she was steeping in her feelings of inferiority, her mood worsening every day.

Jason sat there for a long minute. He thought about what he had told Daisy earlier about himself when he was a teenager. He was a lot like Farrah back then. He had felt inferior to other people and immediately sought to use his power to make himself into a 'cooler' version of himself. But that was only putting a band-aid on the real issue.

Farrah possessed an admittedly simple power, but it was still something that basically no other humans would ever possess. The issue was, she was surrounded by other superhumans who were, at least in her eyes, objectively superior to her in every way. Even Jason himself could change the way he looked with great ease, possessing superior appearance-changing powers to her.

What was her power again? Jason wondered.

He recalled that she could change the appearance of her face, and... that was about it.

Oh, *and* she could change the color of her hair too. Jason remembered that Farrah had shifted her hair from blonde to white when he first met her.

Jason got up and walked over to Farrah. She'd gone silent by now, and seemed embarrassed about flipping out in front of him. He sat down next to her, a thoughtful expression on his face.

"So, Farrah. Your power... you can change your facial appearance, and your hair color, right?"

Farrah looked glum. "Yes. That's all."

"It's kind of odd." Jason muttered. "Even for a Lowborn, that seems awfully limited. You're sure that's all you can do?"

"I've tried all sorts of other stuff!" Farrah exclaimed. "Especially after I heard about Emperor Belial. I thought maybe I could change my body more like she does... but it's no use. I can't do anything. I'm nowhere near her level."

"It really is strange." Jason said, as he looked her body up and down. "I know of a Lowborn girl whose only power was to change the direction of the wind, which would make her fall asleep from exhaustion. I think your power is better than hers, but only by a little."

Farrah furrowed her brow. She looked like she was about to burst into tears, having her fragile mental state exacerbated by what felt like the legendary Hero mocking her.

"Sorry, I don't think I'm speaking clearly." Jason quickly said. "I'm not saying your power is weak and useless. I'm saying I think there *has* to be more to it. I don't think you've tapped into the full extent of your abilities, and part of the blame is on me."

Farrah turned her teary eyes to meet his for the first time. "Y-you really think so?"

There was a spark of hope in her eyes, but at the same time, she looked like she was equally prepared for crushing disappointment. It seemed her mental state was much worse than he'd thought.

"I do. Let's go to the medical center." Jason said. "I'll examine you there and see if I can figure out how to boost your powers."

"R-really?" Farrah asked, still in disbelief. "You'd do that for me?"

"Farrah, I've really neglected you. I'm sorry." Jason said, smiling while feeling terrible on the inside. "It wasn't my intention. But since I've neglected your needs, I'll just have to make up for it double-time. Let's take a look and see if there's anything I can do to help you out."

Without further ado, Jason teleported himself and Farrah into the same medical facility where he'd been upgrading other people's MindCores. His daughter was up next, but he hadn't yet finished the upgrades to his process, and he was fearful he could hurt her like he did Nadia... Jason *definitely* didn't want to do to Daisy what he'd done to Catherine. He was not ready to give her a Freudian complex for the rest of her life... *by no means*.

"Just lay back in this chair." Jason said. He didn't bother strapping Farrah in, since he wasn't doing anything invasive today.

Jason started by firing up his lab equipment. Farrah seemed nervous, but there was visible excitement in her eyes. The Archseer himself was going to see if he could amplify her powers. Who wouldn't be excited?!

Jason started by running a scanner to examine her 'mundane' biology. It scanned her cells, examined her skin and bones, and peered within her brain and spine to uncover whatever her metaphysical powers might have altered about her physical self.

Before long, Jason started mumbling to himself. "Hmm... huh... hmm... interesting. Oh, and that...? But it couldn't... hmm, and this here..."

He was so engrossed in examining the scans of Farrah's body that when he raised his head and saw Farrah looking at him with teary-eyes, he was taken aback.

"Farrah?" Jason asked.

"D-did you f-find anything?" Farrah asked. "You look... like it's... really b-bad..."

From her perspective, Jason's expression had turned so deadly serious that he looked like he'd just found out she had terminal cancer. Farrah was going crazy from his lack of communication!

"Oh! No, no, it's nothing like that." Jason said, quickly rifling through the paper printouts. He plucked out an image of Farrah's brain. "See here? There's a lot of activity in your Hippocampus compared to the other Lowborn. This shows that your metaphysical powers primarily originate from your brain, not your body. And the Hippocampus

especially is involved with short and long term memory, as well as your spatial navigation."

He continued. "So, basically, your power is mainly cerebral. What's curious to me is that based on what I'm seeing, it seems to be primarily focused on your head as a whole. That could explain why only your face and hair change. Could you start using your powers while I scan you? It would give me a better range of data now that I've established the baseline."

"Um. Okay. Sure." Farrah agreed.

After a few moments, she started focusing her mind. Her face shifted, and she took on the appearance of Daisy, even mimicking her hair color to match Daisy's particular hue of blonde.

"Oh! Interesting!" Jason said, looking into his observation equipment as it showed different parts of Farrah's brain lighting up. "Try changing your appearance to a male one. Can you shift your face into Jerome's?"

Farrah winced. "You... want me to turn into my boyfriend...?"

"Yes." Jason said, before giving her a weird look of his own. "Don't tell me you haven't tried that before?"

"Turning into a boy is kind of weird..." Farrah said hesitantly. "I don't know, won't that make me a *queer*?"

Jason blinked twice. What the heck was she talking about?

"You're telling me you've never made yourself look like a guy before?"

"Well, no..." Farrah said, looking away sheepishly. "I'm a girl. I want to look like a girl. Why would I want to turn into a boy?"

"Farrah." Jason said seriously. "I have more reasons why you would and should than why you wouldn't or shouldn't. You know, I've even... never mind that. Just do it for me, this once, okay?"

Jason almost stated that he had done the same, making a female version of himself via Jessica Harper, but he opted not to. Only a select few were privileged to know that information, as well as people he'd accidentally let it slip, like Nadia and Catherine.

The fewer who knew, the lower the chance of leaks.

Farrah listened to Jason's request. After a moment, she nodded her head shyly.

"O-okay. I'll, um, try turning into a b-boy..." She said.

It took her a lot of effort, and more time than Jason expected. Even after three minutes, she only seemed to be grunting and squirming uncomfortably. Jason raised his eyebrow. It seemed she really felt discomforted by the thought of doing so.

Still, Jason kept monitoring her vitals. Eventually, he noticed the fluctuations of mental and spiritual energy inside her brain that indicated she was activating her powers. He flicked his eyes between Farrah and the monitor every so often.

Eventually, Farrah's skin started to darken. It turned from white to brown to a richer, darker shade of black as she mimicked Jerome's skin color. She was plenty familiar with how he looked, so it seemed mimicking his appearance was fairly simple.

Farrah had her eyes closed. She didn't even realize that her powers were working. Jason, however, *did*. For the first time, Farrah managed to change the color of not only her face, but all the rest of her body as well! Her nose slightly enlarged. Her forehead became slightly more prominent, and her lower jaw jutted out a little. Once she started successfully transitioning, she seemed to break past a mental barrier, and the rest of her body shifted to look like a much skinnier and more feminine version of Jerome!

When Farrah finished and opened her eyes, she gasped in shock. She sat up in the chair and looked down at her hands and arms.

"I, I, I...??" Farrah stuttered.

"You did it." Jason said, walking over to her with a smile. "You were limiting yourself the whole time. I thought I might need to alter your body's powers or something, but it seems I didn't need to. You had the ability in you all along."

Farrah looked like she was in a daze. "This is... I can... change my whole body? Not only my head?"

"I don't know the exact reason, but it seems you were holding back this entire time." Jason explained. "Maybe some sense of shame? Guilt? Some other reason? Have you never tried to turn into a man before?"

Farrah looked at him, then quickly looked away. "N-no. I haven't... before. It's not... in Persia, a woman dressing as a man is... shameful. My mother, my father, they wouldn't like it."

Ah. Mommy and daddy issues. Jason thought. *Nothing to unpack there...*

He didn't voice such crude words out loud. Instead, he smiled encouragingly. "This is just the first step, you know. You forced yourself to turn into a guy, but now I want you to practice all by yourself, in your room or somewhere else. Once you learn how to transition more seamlessly, you'll definitely be able to turn into different sorts of men and women more naturally."

Jason tapped his chin thoughtfully. "Hmm, but what about your voice? Your physical build and bone structure? I bet this is still only the beginning. What you've done now is turn yourself into a crude facsimile of your boyfriend. You need to keep practicing until you can turn into an exact replica of him in a split-second!"

"But what if I can't?" Farrah asked. "What if I've already reached my limit?"

Jason rested his palm on Farrah's shoulder and gave her a reassuring squeeze. "Farrah, five minutes ago, the 'limit' of what you could do was lower than it was now. Instead of constantly second-guessing yourself, try demanding more of yourself. You're a Specialist, and your specialty is shapeshifting. I'm willing to bet good money you still have a long ways to go before you reach the so-called limit of your powers."

"Oh... okay." Farrah said. She looked skeptical, but she couldn't help smiling. Her expression was brighter than before. It seemed Jason's words had caused the intended effects. "Y-you're right. I'm always so... ashamed. So worried others will look down on me. Maybe that's been... holding me back... all this time."

Jason sighed. He didn't know much about Farrah. For her to always be so anxious and nervous, there must be a story behind it. It seemed Jerome was always kind and sweet and loving with her. It was unlikely he was berating or insulting her behind closed doors. Something must have caused her to develop her constant anxiety, but Jason wasn't certain what it was.

There was always tomorrow, and the day after. They'd made a breakthrough today. Best to leave the deeper questions for later. He'd neglected her for long enough.

"Just keep practicing." Jason encouraged. "I'll start following up with you from now on. Sorry that I ignored you before... I've been busy, but that's not a good enough excuse."

"It's fine. You're the Archseer. You're a busy man." Farrah said, smiling sweetly. "Th-thank you for helping me. It means... m-means a lot to me."

The two of them said their goodbyes, and Jason returned her to the pool where he'd originally found her.

Now that Jason had weakened the mental limiter holding her back, his thoughts turned toward other matters.

"If Farrah has hidden potential, I wonder about the rest." Jason muttered to himself. "We've got a year to train before the demons attack. Every little gain early on will pay out dividends later."

He went silent for a moment.

"I should pay Brian Bozzard a visit..."

Part 773: Best of Intentions

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

A full week passed inside Aevum after Jason spoke to his daughter and Farrah, amounting to slightly less than four minutes in Realspace.

During that time, Jason was not idly sitting around. He worked with Harold to develop a training program for each of Aevum's teenagers, and, at the same time, he put the final touches on the v4 MindCores.

Each iteration of MindCore had become noticeably more compact, energy efficient, and easier to install on top of a person's Mind Realm. Even though they had reached v4, the true quality upgrade of a v1 to a v4 MindCore was about 2x, sometimes 2.5x. This meant that if Jason updated his v1 GenesisFrame to a v4, it would perform a bit better than twice as well in all categories.

His thinking speed would double, his intangible 'creative ability' would double, his inventiveness, and so on.

Those were extreme benefits, but aside from the qualitative improvements, what Jason truly valued the most in each new iteration were the reduction in installation requirements. He still shuddered when he thought of how he'd had to install his v1 GenesisFrame into his own mind. The agony of that day, the length of the procedure, and the fact that he had nearly died, and many times had *wished* he'd died, had carved an indelible trauma onto his heart.

Jason smacked his lips with dissatisfaction. Even though the v2 and v3 MindCores had been huge improvements over v1, he'd still traumatized Nadia and Catherine both, and also caused them to weirdly... 'fixate' on him. Jason wasn't stupid. He could tell both women had looked at him very differently before and after the procedures.

Naturally, he couldn't reciprocate their interest. In his heart, he was still a married man, and the guilt he carried regarding Phoebe's death had not faded in the slightest. He still thought about her every day, especially now that he actually saw her younger self walking around Aevum.

* * *

Today was the day.

One week after talking to Daisy and Farrah, after finishing the last touches on his v4 MindCores, he decided it was time for him to start upgrading all the teenagers to the newest iterations.

Jason had spent the entirety of his development time between v3 and v4 working on reducing the pain of installation, broadening the the safety parameters, and making them function on other species as well. Now if he wanted to install a MindCore on a non-human-based Sentient, it was possible for him to do so. Unfortunately, even the v4 MindCore could not be installed inside someone with a Mind Realm already unless their Mind Realm was destroyed first, like he'd done with Catherine.

Maybe someday he'd come up with a solution for this problem, but that day was not today.

Jason chewed his fingernails nervously. He pored over his schematics ten times, scrutinizing them over and over to try and find any problems. Only after he was fully satisfied did he finally step out of his secret Inner Sanctum to appear at the entrance to Nadia's room. He knocked on it, and a minute later, the door opened.

Nadia looked at Jason with the same ordinary level of attentiveness she always did. Her emotions were always subdued, but her eyes *did* sparkle ever so slightly when she looked at him. Today she was wearing a casual blue dress with an ankle-length skirt. She'd let her bob-cut hair grow out a bit, and now it fell down to her neck.

Privately, Jason mused to himself that she was dressing more like a proper older woman. She didn't have the immaturity and inexperience of a teenage girl anymore, and she carried herself with a certain assertiveness that spoke of inner self-confidence. Many teenagers and young adults were unsure about their capabilities, their place in the world, and what they could accomplish. This often made it difficult for them to walk with confidence, and that limited mindset was noticeable to adults who'd been around longer.

But mentally, Nadia was not eighteen anymore. She had lived 72 years inside her RealitySim, plus who-knew how much extra time after Jason granted her administrative control. That meant mentally she was in her 90's, if not older.

"Yes?" Nadia asked.

"Today's the day." Jason said, his tone serious. "I finished the v4's. I need you to look them over."

"Okay." Nadia answered.

Nadia had never been much of a talker in her youth. Now that she was mentally a grandmother, she kept her sentences even more concise. She didn't seem to like expending her breath needlessly. Was that her 'old person trait'? Or was it just what she had matured into naturally over the years? Jason wasn't sure.

A moment later, Jason teleported Nadia into a small facility on the northern edge of Aevum. Inside, he had set up five different exhibits that detailed all his notes and progress on v4 of the MindCores.

It didn't take long to catch Nadia up to speed. She casually downloaded the notes into her RealitySim and listened while Jason talked, explaining his various design decisions.

"Right there, you said you reduced the transfer speed between Conduits R33 and S15 by 3%." Nadia said, pointing at one of the diagrams. "This is going to cause a slowdown of 7% further down the line due to inefficiencies here, here, and here. This isn't a problem for most of the MindCores, but it's going to affect the OmniRecord the most. Since it's the most general-purpose MindCore, focusing especially on improving thinking speed, memory, and memory recall, this is going to cause a 15% deviation in memory recall speeds related to emotion."

Jason scrunched up his face. "I don't know... I mean, you're not wrong, but it's only affecting emotional memories, not logical ones, so in terms of pure utility it won't hurt a general purpose user. Also, the lower transfer speed might be bad, but it reduces the installation pain by about three or four Mental-Joules."

"Installation pain only happens one time." Nadia said, shaking her head. "I understand wanting to cut down on installation pain and friction as much as possible, but if you cut too many corners and sacrifice performance here and there, you'll drastically reduce the effectiveness of the MindCore itself, defeating the purpose."

She gave him a knowing look. "Even with the pain and trauma I faced, I wouldn't be as happy with my MindCore if it meant a reduction in my final capabilities. I've gained far more than I lost."

Jason's expression fell. "Can you really say that? After what happened?"

"I can." Nadia answered. "It was torturous. It was painful. But in the end, I think the process was worth it. What hurt the most was the uncertainty. Not knowing whether all my friends were dying of old age while I was trapped inside my own mind. But after I got out and found only a few minutes had passed, that pain faded. In the end, I gained decades of knowledge, wisdom, and experience within just a few minutes. This will make me a more effective savior of humanity and the people I love."

Her eyes seemed to linger on Jason's when she mentioned that last part. Jason looked away and pretended not to notice.

"I guess I see your point." Jason muttered. "Alright, I'll adjust that relay point. Anything else?"

"Yes." Nadia said, immediately returning to the task at hand without addressing the strange atmosphere between herself and the Wordsmith. "Over here, and here, you'll notice..."

Several hours passed. Jason's v4 MindCores were ever so slightly tweaked and adjusted based on Nadia's words. Every so often, she would close her eyes and fall silent. Jason realized she was running simulations of the MindCores inside her RealitySim, which was in itself a bit of a mindfuck. How accurately could her RealitySim emulate the improvements of a more advanced RealitySim? Was that even possible? Jason wasn't sure. Without a RealitySim of his own, he genuinely didn't know just how formidable hers was.

It definitely helped that her Lowborn power granted her incredible comprehension powers. Nadia's RealitySim became far more capable than Catherine's as a result.

"I think we're good to go." Jason said, as he finalized the v4 designs. His heart jumped slightly as he realized the time to drag his feet was over. "I'm going to... finally do it."

"Who goes first?" Nadia asked. "Personally, I think you should give Daisy the first upgrade."

"Daisy..." Jason said, lowering his head. "I... I don't know. What if something goes wrong?"

"Afraid daddy's little girl will develop a genuine *daddy* complex?" Nadia teased. "If I were you, I'd definitely be worried about corrupting her pure and innocent youthful thoughts too."

Jason facepalmed. "Yes, that *is* a big thing holding me back. I already fucked up the minds of two women... no offense. I don't want to twist my daughter's brain. I would never live it down."

"No offense taken." Nadia said with a faint smile. "Jason, Catherine and I both knew it wasn't intentional. It wasn't your fault. I guarantee you won't give your daughter a *daddy complex*. These new MindCores no longer have the same side effects as... *mine* did."

Jason shuddered. He really didn't want to think of Daisy looking at him with the same gaze Catherine did after her surgery. Phoebe would probably come back from the dead and beat him to a pulp for being so irresponsible.

"You're sure it will work out okay, then?" Jason asked, uncertainty in his voice.

"From v4 onward, the side effects will be minimized." Nadia assured him. "There will still be pain, but only about as much as a particularly unenjoyable dentist visit."

"Eugh." Jason grimaced, pulling his hand off his face. "You know that still sounds awful, right?"

"Sure." Nadia acknowledged. "But if going to the dentist was extremely painful, yet it also made you a million times smarter, I think most people would take that trade."

Jason mulled her words over. "Fair point."

A moment passed. Jason started to speak, to tell Nadia he'd be right back to fetch Daisy, but she raised her hand to silence him.

"Before you go, I need something from you." Nadia said. "I want to be there during Daisy's soul surgery, but I won't be able to contribute meaningfully without seeing what's going on."

Jason blinked. "Yes, I was going to ask if you could assist me. I was planning to jury-rig something up so you could see what was going on."

"No need." Nadia said. "I've already developed a prototype. Please take a look at this schematic."

She lifted her index finger and pointed it toward Jason. Jason nodded slowly, then raised his own index finger and touched it to hers. This allowed the two of them to transmit their thoughts directly into each other's minds; a recent improvement Jason had made for all MindCore users. Their left and right index fingers were capable of coupling

to transmit information instantly, and only consensually, of course. One's thoughts could not be stolen without the owner's knowledge while they were asleep or something.

A moment later, Nadia transmitted the schematic into Jason's mind. He fell silent as he rapidly analyzed it with his GenesisFrame.

"This..." Jason said slowly. "It's a... scanning device that attaches to a MindCore? Like a real-world augment?"

"That's right." Nadia said. "I made it primarily for myself, but it has many other potential applications. Its primary purpose is to allow me to scan the thoughts, memories, physical composition, and spiritual information of other entities from a distance. It has an effective range of only about twenty meters, and the information quality will rapidly degrade past that range... but it's useful for my needs."

Jason scratched his chin. "This device hooks onto the side of your head, covers one of your eyes, and allows you to learn a *lot* about a person with a single scan. It won't be very effective against powerful entities like Demon Dukes, Psions, and so on. Anyone with a MindCore will passively resist the scan, anyone with a Mind Realm, even just people with strong spiritual energy..."

"That's right. It's the limit of what I could accomplish for now." Nadia said with a shrug. "It'll help me monitor Daisy's condition during the surgery without having to invasively 'hook in' to her MindCore during construction. Beyond that, this device has a few other practical uses that primarily benefit me."

Jason's eyes flicked away from the schematic to meet Nadia's gaze.

"This device is... dangerous, you know. It violates people's privacy without them knowing."

"A lot like your Spynet." Nadia immediately countered crossing her arms.

Jason flinched. "How do you...?"

He didn't finish the sentence. She'd spent 72 years with a perfect replica of himself. Naturally, she'd learned all his secrets, even regarding things like the Spynet, the Star-net he used to defeat Hope, and so on.

"You know, Jason, for someone worried about 'invading' other people's privacy, you sure seem to do it a lot." Nadia said, meeting his gaze with a stare of her own. "I'm not judging you for your Spynet. I get it. I really do. But it's a dangerous thing to invent. Even

the Volgrim don't have a direct equivalent that can peek into the private living spaces of their citizens. My device is invasive, but its purpose will strengthen Aevum, which is what you should care about most."

Jason softly sighed. He looked away.

"Let me guess. You will use this to download knowledge from Earth's smartest people, convert it into usable data to improve your simulations, and rapidly scale up the capabilities of your MindCore."

"That's right." Nadia said. "I can't build it without your help, though. Several internal parts rely on 'Imagi-Tech' that only a Wordsmith can build. This also means that even if it falls off my head and gets lost, nobody can replicate the device except another Wordsmith."

That satisfied Jason. He looked at the device and chuckled. "It's pretty useful. Might even make one for myself. What should we call it. A Scouter?"

"No. It has nothing to do with scouting." Nadia said, raising an eyebrow. "It's obviously a scanning device. Let's call it a PepScan."

"Well, I was thinking we could call it a Scouter because it kinda looks like... eh, never mind." Jason said, tossing the idea aside when he saw Nadia roll her eyes. "It's your invention anyway, so you get to name it. PepScan it is."

Jason rapidly configured the schematics in his mind, then he began to utter Words of Power, one after the other.

"**Materialize. Augment. Manifest. Circuits. Integrate. Meld. Mold. Observe. Rewire. Circuits. Observe...**"

It took him several long minutes, but eventually, he finished. The completed PepScan was held in his grasp. He stuck it to the side of his head, and it magically adhered without actually touching his skin or hair. He couldn't feel the weight of it at all. It was as if the PepScan was magnetically attached to his skull, but with a cushion of air in-between.

Jason looked at Nadia. He tapped the side of the PepScan, causing a stream of data to flow into his mind. Immediately, he was able to get a readout on her physical attributes, including her height, weight, genetic ancestry, and all sorts of other biological information. However, all scans of her brain provided garbled static. Since she had a

MindCore, her brain and Mind Realm were shielded by an invisible fortress of spirituality.

Jason disappeared from the spot, taking himself and Nadia into his SpyNet. This was the first time he'd ever brought anyone inside, but since she already knew, there wasn't much point in keeping it hidden from her. Either he trusted her, or he didn't. He decided to lean further into their relationship, rather than holding up a pretentious barrier that held only symbolic meaning.

Like this, Jason casually picked a random old lady in Iowa. He scanned her, and all sorts of information came up. He captured all of her surface level knowledge, he downloaded her wisdom and insights, and even obtained all the information he needed on how to become a fairly solid and reputable sweater-knitter. Unfortunately, unless he practiced, that knowledge wouldn't prove much use.

Additionally, due to the fact he was remotely viewing her, rather than observing her from less than twenty meters away, a massive amount of the data came back garbled. Anything taken from her thoughts and soul ended up being corrupted to the point he wasn't sure if the information was reliable at all. Only physical details about her body appeared reliable.

"This PepScanner is... worrying." Jason said. "It's already bad enough to be spying on people without their knowledge. But to even extract their most secret memories and desires...?"

"I really do need it." Nadia said. "Not only to help you with Daisy, but to become the best brainiac possible for Aevum. This tool will improve my mental progress by a minimum factor of ten, and possibly up to fifty in some areas."

"Tell me the truth." Jason said, as he directed a wary look at her. "Are you planning to use this for any illicit reasons? Spying on old boyfriends? Taking revenge on people who've harmed you?"

"Old boyfriends?" Nadia scoffed. "Jason, you're the only..."

She paused, swallowing the words involuntarily. She looked away, her expression inscrutable. "No. I'm not going to use it to harm you, humanity, or anyone else. You can use your Wordsmithing to bind me to that promise if you like. It's probably for the best that you do."

A long moment passed as Jason considered doing just that. Nadia was already capable of vastly exceeding him when it came to intelligence. The PepScan would increase that level even further. A true superintelligence could not be limited by someone or something less intelligent. It just wasn't possible. Any restrictions Jason could think of, she could eventually break.

A thought came to him in that moment. This was the last chance he had to put a limiter on Nadia. Once he handed her the PepScan, he would be handing over total faith in her intentions. If she ever turned against him it would be a catastrophe.

It was clear that Nadia knew this. Even she feared what she could become. Right now he was 100% certain she was on his side. But what about a year from now, or ten years, or a thousand, or a million?

Would the state of today exist forever? Jason seriously doubted it.

"Nadia." Jason said, his tone solemn. "Did you delete that internal copy of me? The mental clone made from my memories?"

Nadia winced. She didn't meet his gaze.

"...No. I didn't." Nadia said quietly.

"I thought not." Jason said. "This PepScan has several hallmarks that indicate I myself must have designed it, not you. It even looks like something from an anime I used to watch. Why didn't you delete my mental copy?"

This time, a long, uncomfortable silence followed.

Nadia still couldn't look Jason in the eye. She rubbed her arms and turned her head even further away.

"I couldn't bring myself to kill him." Nadia eventually said. "I love you. I love him. I know you'll never love me. Your heart will always belong to Phoebe. If I killed him, I'd be killing the man I love."

Jason licked his lips. He sighed through his teeth.

"Did you tamper with my mental clone?" Jason asked.

Nadia finally looked at him. Her expression was one of awe at his guessing-ability. "Yes... I erased his memories of your family. I made him love me the way you love Phoebe."

"That's *really* fucked up." Jason said. "How can I trust you to do the right thing with this PepScanner if you're already doing questionable things like that?"

"I don't know." Nadia answered. "Maybe you shouldn't. Maybe I shouldn't have such a power. But this? All of this? Everything that's happened to me? This is on you."

Jason turned his whole body to face her. "Me? You're blaming me?"

"I was content to keep my powers hidden. I couldn't even use them without slowly dying a painful death of hollowed-out bones and a broken body." Nadia said, firming her resolve as she turned and faced him. "But you came back in time and changed the trajectory of my life. Before I met you, I was likely going to die from using my powers, or wallow in mediocrity with a broken body. You gave me a new lease on life and asked me to be your 'right hand assistant.'"

But Nadia was not done there. "You gave me my MindCore. You locked me in that mental prison and changed the trajectory of my life even further. I'm not the person I was before I came to Aevum, and that Nadia is never coming back. After filling me with all these feelings, even if you did it accidentally, you asked me to kill the only person who I was able to bond with over seven long decades in a mental prison."

Nadia shrugged her shoulders. "If not you, then who is responsible?"

"I understand what I've done to you. And I'm sorry." Jason said. "But you chose to rewrite that... that fake-me in your mind. Turn him into someone he's not. I didn't do that to you."

"No... but you *are* being a huge hypocrite right now, Jason." Nadia shot back. "First you build a SpyNet, then you worry I'll use the PepScan to invade people's privacy while ignoring that you're doing the same thing. Now you're concerned with what I did to my Mind Jason, but aren't you forgetting something? Or rather, *someone*? Namely... Fiona?"

Jason winced. He immediately lowered his eyes. Her retort came so smoothly that he hadn't seen it coming. And now that she mentioned it...

"I... I didn't rewrite Fiona's thoughts to turn her into a love slave." Jason muttered.

It was a feeble argument, and he knew it.

"No, you didn't do that." Nadia acknowledged. "But you *did* make a clone of your wife without her knowledge, then you put that clone in your head. In a way, you cheated on Phoebe, even if only mentally, with Fiona. Worse yet, while Fiona loved you *just* as much

as the real Phoebe did, you ultimately split her off and locked her inside Chrona. In a way, her situation mirrors mine. You got to return home to a loving wife, but what about Fiona? You tore her from a life with you and left her alone, trapped in a dimension of your making."

After half a second of silence, Nadia took a figurative step back. "I'll admit that altering the memories of my beloved is certainly *fucked up*. But what were the alternatives? Erase him from existence? Let him remember the family who would never treat him as their beloved? That would be the same as what you did to Fiona."

Jason's expression was one of gloominess. Now it was him who couldn't meet Nadia's eyes.

Her words were not spoken with hostility, but merely the plain facts as she saw them. She did not call Jason a hypocrite merely to force him into giving her what she wanted, but to enlighten him and make him see the error in his ways.

This time, a full minute passed before Jason answered.

"Those are all... good points." Jason muttered. "I hadn't given these matters as much thought as I should have. I'm sorry."

"I'm sorry, too." Nadia said, as she fidgeted uncomfortably. "I didn't even want to say all that. I'd have preferred we just shoved everything under the table."

"No. You were right to say what you did." Jason asserted. He met her gaze. "I've been a hypocrite. It doesn't mean my criticisms are wrong. It doesn't mean that misusing this tool is okay, simply because I've misused a similar tool. But it's given me food for thought."

Jason gestured around himself broadly. "I made the Spynet to keep an eye on my enemies. But I don't know if it's *right* to have invented it in the first place. If humanity were not facing multiple existential threats, I would never have considered it. Even so, is giving up privacy for the sake of security the right decision? I don't know. I definitely wouldn't want this tool falling into the wrong hands."

"I agree." Nadia said. "The question is, are *any* hands the 'right' ones? Is it okay for you, of all people, to possess such power? Or me? Are we inherently more moral and virtuous than others?"

Jason snorted. "I'm certainly not. God. I don't know. This is making my head hurt. Here, just take the PepScan."

The Wordsmith pulled the PepScan off his head and tossed it toward her. Nadia caught it with a quick snap of her wrist. She didn't immediately put it on, but instead stared at it for a long while, feeling the weight of it in her hands.

"It's a shame we live in such interesting times." Nadia remarked. "I wanted to be an ordinary girl. Go to a university. Meet a nice young man. Raise a family. Live in a big house, and die of old age with my husband and children at my side."

"I don't know. That sounds awfully boring." Jason chuckled. "A lot of things have sucked since I got my Wordsmithing, but I've never once gotten tired of wielding godlike powers at the whisper of a word. Being superhuman is pretty badass."

"Yes. It is." Nadia smiled.

She put on the PepScan, allowing it to adhere to the side of her head.

"I meant what I said, Jason. I won't break my promise." Nadia vowed. "Everything I do will be for the good of humanity, for you, and for everyone we care about. I'm not going to betray you."

"I believe you." Jason said with a smile.

And he did. At least for now.

But he couldn't help quietly worrying about the future and whether he'd made yet another terrible mistake in this moment.

Only time would tell.

Part 774: MindCore v4

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Daisy stepped inside the surgery room inside Aevum, the very same one where Nadia and Catherine previously both had their MindCores installed. As she stepped inside, the anxiety and excitement on her face mixed into an indeterminate blob of both, causing her to oscillate between both at the same time, constantly. She was anxious due to all the side effects that could happen, and had happened, to Nadia and Catherine both. She was excited because both of them had clearly demonstrated the value of their MindCores, to say nothing of her own father.

Jason and Nadia were already inside the surgery room. Unlike 'real' doctors on Earth, they weren't wearing surgical garb, but instead, their normal clothes. Nadia looked a little apprehensive, but Jason was all smiles. Daisy wasn't sure if he was confident the surgery was sure to be a success after all his new improvements, or if he simply didn't want her to be afraid of the potential screw-ups that could happen inside her head soon.

"Hey, sweetie." Jason said, as he walked over and kissed his daughter's cheek. "Don't worry. Nadia helped me iron out a lot of kinks. This is going to be the smoothest surgery ever."

Daisy bobbed her head, but her stomach was in knots. "I... I really hope so, dad."

She looked at Nadia for reassurance, but the anxiety on Nadia's face didn't make Daisy feel any better.

After a long moment of hesitation, Daisy sat down in the surgery chair, and Jason reclined it backward, giving him full access to Daisy's head. For several seconds, he simply stood there, resting his hand on Daisy's shoulder.

"Honey, at Nadia's request, I'm going to give you a choice today." Jason said.

"A choice?" Daisy asked.

"Yeah. Basically, you pick from one of two types of MindCores. They're both going to be the v4 QuantumReflex you chose, but they come in different levels of 'potency' and installation difficulty."

Jason was standing on Daisy's left side. Nadia stepped over to her right.

"Basically, it's the choice between a MindCore and a MindCore Lite." Nadia explained. "The reason there's so much pain in the MindCore installation process is because we're trying to maximize every available piece of your Mind Realm to squeeze out performance and optimization. Your father, Catherine, and I all have 'full' MindCores. It made our MindCores *painful* to install, to say the least."

"But today, I helped your father design a pared-down version." Nadia continued. "Effectively, the v4 QuantumReflex Lite will have about the same performance level as the v1, albeit slightly superior, but it will be a lot smaller and more efficient, leaving 20% of your Mind Realm unused. That extra capacity means we won't be 'cramming' a full model in your head. The installation process will be, effectively, painless. You'll get a massive upgrade in your cognitive capabilities and it won't hurt at all."

Daisy looked at her dad. He smiled excitedly, seemingly wanting his daughter to pick the painless option. Then she looked back at Nadia.

"So… it won't hurt to install. But how much better is the full model?" Daisy inquired.

"The full model has a bit more than twice the power." Nadia admitted. "The 20% decrease in Mind Realm utilization also cuts the capabilities of the Lite Model in half. Naturally, this means someone with a Full model will think and react two times faster than someone with a Lite model."

Daisy's eyes immediately lost their shine. "I'm a Trueborn. I won't sacrifice my future capabilities just to endure a little less pain now. No pain, no gain. Give me the Full model, even if it hurts."

Jason squeezed Daisy's shoulder. "Honey, are you sure?"

"Dad, will the installation of the v4 Quantum Reflex Full model hurt as much as Nadia's v3 did?" Daisy asked, looking her father in the eye.

"No." Jason admitted. "We've done everything we could to make it a lot less painful."

"If you, Catherine, and Nadia could all endure the pain, then so can I." Daisy said, firming her resolve. "I won't accept less."

That ended the discussion. Daisy had made up her mind. Jason sighed. "Alright."

His smile faded a bit. As expected, his daughter was a lot like her mother. Phoebe wouldn't give up an opportunity to strengthen herself, and she wasn't afraid of enduring

pain either. It made Jason proud, but it also scared him. He didn't want to hurt his little girl and make her cry. What father would?

Several minutes passed. Jason and Nadia took turns explaining the installation process to Daisy, with Jason explaining how the old one worked while Nadia focused on the improved system. Even though Daisy initially had no idea what was involved in a MindCore installation, she became shocked out of her mind when she compared her father's original methods to the new and improved ones.

"Dad, you ripped apart Catherine's Mind Realm and rebuilt it from scratch?" Daisy asked in shock. "You're lucky you didn't turn her into a cripple!"

"Yeah..." Jason said, averting his gaze. "And you wouldn't believe how much more painful it would have been if I were trying to install my v1 into her Mind Realm. The v2 and v3 were lightyears more advanced, and the v4 even beyond those. It will definitely be a lot less painful."

With the explanations out of the way, Jason got to work. Nadia attached the PepScan to the side of her head. It immediately started providing her with detailed readouts of Daisy's physiology, but her strong spirituality repelled it from reading her innermost thoughts and desires.

At the very least, Nadia could see the state of Daisy's Mind Realm, or the lack of it, for that matter.

Jason dove into Daisy's brain. When he arrived, he was extremely surprised. "Whoa... the spiritual energy in your undeveloped Mind Realm is richer than mine! This... this is crazy. I didn't know my little girl was so formidable."

"Yeah, yeah." Daisy said, feeling discomforted by the tingling sensations in her head, as well as her father poking around in there. "Just... get it over with, dad."

"Okay." Jason said.

After validating the amount of space he had available in Daisy's Mind Realm, Jason immediately got to work tilling the latent energy within her. He spoke Words of Power one after another, causing the unfocused mana within her body to spring to life. It was at this point that, silently, Jason started to realize something.

Daisy's soul is rainbow-colored, like mine. Is that why she has such a vast array of powers at her disposal? If I'm not careful, I could taint her energy and lock down her

powers, reducing the diversity of options available to her.

Jason started work on Daisy's MindCore. Her QuantumReflex was based on monster physiology, and its main purpose was to give her enhanced reflexes, among other monstrous mental capabilities. Jason wasn't actually entirely sure what the effects would be, as ridiculous as that sounded. In the same way he didn't originally know exactly what it would 'be like' to have a GenesisFrame, or all the other minor drawbacks and benefits of such a thing, Jason wasn't entirely certain what abilities Daisy would obtain.

The RealitySim was relatively straightforward compared to the QuantumReflex. Jason used the power of Titan minds to create a MindCore that could simulate worlds. He hadn't anticipated accidentally locking Nadia into a 72-year torture simulator, but in the end, the RealitySim did about what he expected it to do. It was effectively a fully manipulable Holodeck inside Nadia and Catherine's minds.

But the QuantumReflex? It was a mish-mash of hundreds of different animal and monster brain simulations. Jason had picked and chosen from many different Earth and extra-terrestrial creatures to create v4 of the QuantumReflex, but aside from 'improved reflexes' and 'animal instincts', he just didn't know what it would do to Daisy.

This was, without a doubt, his biggest fear. What if he turned his daughter into a snarling bloodthirsty predator? Jason tried not to dwell on that possibility.

Minutes passed. Daisy squirmed a little, but otherwise laid still in the chair, her eyes closed. Jason operated smoothly and efficiently on her brain. By the point when Nadia and Catherine had started experiencing severe agonizing pain or pleasure, Daisy wasn't even gritting her teeth all that hard. Certainly, she was in pain. It felt like someone was slowly tracing a knife across her chest, back, and throat. But... it wasn't to the point she'd rather die.

Jason started to perspire. Before he could even think about it, Nadia had already grabbed a cloth and dabbed his forehead. Jason glanced at her for a split second, then returned his gaze to Daisy.

Nadia's move had been rather... intimate. The way she moved was as if she were his wife, lovingly dabbing his forehead so he wouldn't sweat all over his daughter.

Jason tried not to think about the implications of her actions. Now simply wasn't the time.

Just as Jason was starting to get into the mid-stages of Daisy's operation, his face spasmed. A jolt of pain just under his eyes made him wince.

What the hell was that? Jason thought. He felt like someone had slapped him across the face.

He blinked three times to clear his vision. Strange white spots danced in his vision.

After a moment, they went away. Jason frowned. This had never happened during the previous surgeries. Was he about to encounter another awful situation with his daughter?

He hesitated for a few seconds. He didn't want to hurt Daisy, but she didn't look to be in a lot of pain. If Nadia had been at a 9 out of 10 on the pain scale by this point of the surgery, Daisy was barely cresting a 4.

The surgery was going smoothly. Jason didn't dare to delay. He continued with the original plan.

Jason started melding bits and pieces of animal knowledge and instincts into Daisy's MindCore. As it slowly started to take shape, another jolt of pain shot into Jason's irises. He quickly squeezed his eyes shut and gritted his teeth.

"No, stop!" Daisy shouted. Jason gasped. Her voice sounded... child-like. Not like her current self.

He opened his eyes again. Nothing was amiss. Daisy continued to lay in the chair, obviously in pain, but not that much.

"Did... you... say something?" Jason asked through gritted teeth.

Daisy wheezed. "No, dad. Just... keep going."

Jason inhaled and exhaled. What the hell had he just heard? He was sure Daisy had said something. But the words didn't seem to actually come from her mouth?

He continued the surgery. This time, he melted part of an eagle's instincts into her. All at once, something struck his face with violent force, making his head snap backward. Jason felt his vision go white as he heard his daughter crying again.

"No, please... it hurts..." Daisy whimpered. "I want... my daddy..."

"You don't have a daddy. You're an orphan." A male voice said. The voice vaguely had a Russian accent to it. "If you want food, then do as I say. Lift the ball."

"I'm scared. I'm scared..." Daisy cried. "Please don't hurt me... I want my mommy..."

"Another injection." The man ordered. "The activity in her hippocampus is still underutilized. Too much activity in her limbic system. Her emotions are causing too many distractions."

A woman's voice spoke. "Doctor, it's been four hours... we should let her rest a while. She's only a child."

"A child with the power of a Hero!" The man snapped. "Get out of my sight! You're too soft!"

Jason felt as if a massive hand had grabbed his throat. He couldn't see anything, but he could feel a powerful hand pinning him in a chair, holding him down.

"Lift the ball. Lift it." The man ordered.

"I'm huck- huck... scared..." Daisy cried, as she struggled to breathe under the man's crushing grip. "Kah... helll-help..."

"You think you're scared now? You'll be pissing yourself once the Director approves the next round of stimulants. Now lift the ball or suffer the consequences."

The world came slightly into focus. Jason could just barely make out the shape of a face close to his. A masculine face. Jason felt that there was a blindfold covering his eyes. It was not as if Jason was seeing the face with his eyes, but some other sense. He could not only sense the scary face, monstrous like that of a demon, but also a hand and arm squeezing him by the throat.

An upright palm came into view with a small ball resting atop it. The man brought the palm closer.

"Lift. The ball." The man ordered.

"Nnn... c-can't... breathe..." Daisy gasped. She tried to move her arms, but they were strapped to the chair, along with her little legs. She was completely helpless, and terrified out of her mind.

"You'll BREATHE when you lift the BALL!" The man roared.

Daisy's vision faded. She passed out from lack of oxygen, and all at once, Jason's mind jolted back to the real world.

He inadvertently took two steps backward. His chest rose and fell with uncontrollable rhythm. He felt as if an anvil were crushing down on top of him.

It was Daisy's memory. He had experienced a flicker of a scene from her past.

He, a two hundred year old man, had been utterly terrified by the cruelty he just endured.

How would a six or seven year old girl, alone and helpless, have felt?!

"Jason?" Nadia asked with a frown.

Jason's eyes flicked over to her. His pupils were shrunken with fear. He was gasping quietly for breath like a man who'd barely survived an encounter with a raging tiger. From Nadia's point of view, he'd suddenly recoiled out of nowhere and started looking around like a madman.

Jason took a few seconds to collect himself. He wiped his arm across his brow. "It's... it's nothing. I just... the surgery is a little... intense."

Jason's fear and panic was already starting to turn into a form of fatherly rage. He'd heard from Daisy that her childhood was miserable. He'd suffered guilt over it, despair at his failure as a father to protect her.

But this was different.

Seeing it, experiencing it, feeling it from her point of view. He understood on an intimate level just how traumatizing that part of her life had been. She had 'only' gone through it from the ages of six to eight, before Vasily Sokolov adopted her.

Two of her formative years, her most vulnerable, were spent doing whatever powerful men had ordered her to do. They'd beaten her, abused her, treated her like a monkey in a cage. More than that, they had hurt her physically and psychologically. They'd molded her into a compliant 'good little girl' who did as she was told out of fear of getting punished.

In this moment, Jason understood, truly understood, why she craved power. She'd been made to feel completely weak and defenseless, and now she wanted to rid herself of that feeling.

Pain? What Jason was doing to her now could hardly even be called that. What was a light stabbing or tingling from the Father who loved her compared to the nonstop choking, slapping, and punching of violent men who abused her?

Jason wanted to cry, but now was not the time. He couldn't leave her in a half-finished state. The longer she sat with an incomplete MindCore, the likelier she would suffer a catastrophic breakdown or loss of mental function.

So Jason quickly got back to work. He ignored Nadia's probing stares. She didn't speak a question, but he could feel one in her gaze.

Jason worked quickly. Every so often, a memory of Daisy's would force its way into his mind. Each one was worse than the last.

A sensation of being pricked in the neck. Lava flowing into Daisy's body. Shrieks of begging, crying, asking the bad man to stop.

A slap sent her flying. She crashed against the wall. Then came loud demands to use her telepathy to kill the calico cat in the cell with her. Daisy did as she was told. The cat let out a shriek of pain before it fell to the ground, spasming as it died. Daisy cried.

Another orphan child, a little girl, was put in the cell with Daisy. She was told to kill the other girl. Break the orphan's neck, but also keep her alive for exactly five minutes, only allowing her to die when the timer ran out. Daisy did as she was told. She was a good girl. She never disobeyed the bad man. It was just the orphan girl's bad luck to end up with her.

They were taking her blood again. Daisy could hear them through the walls, talking about 'higher concentrations' and 'successful experiments'. She tried not to listen. If she performed poorly, they would beat her. If she performed well, they would demand more from her. She was so scared, she had begun to forget what a world without fear even was.

The surgery continued. Tears slid down from Jason's eyes. He didn't even notice when Nadia dabbed them dry. He gritted his teeth and continued to operate on his daughter. The rage he felt was rising to a breaking point. He didn't even know what he was capable of doing right now. His face was red from all the repressed feelings he was trying to keep inside.

And then, all at once, it was over.

The surgery ended. Jason put the last piece of Daisy's MindCore into place, then he sagged where he stood. He looked like he'd aged ten years in two hours.

It had taken a quarter of the time needed to create Daisy's MindCore compared to Nadia or Catherine's, and less than a tenth the time it took to install Jason's v1 GenesisFrame.

But for Jason, suffering the torture Daisy had experienced during her childhood, it felt like he'd spent years installing it. His emotions were in total disarray. He looked as if he'd

stepped into a hurricane and crawled back inside after a gang of men beat the shit out of him. His eyes were baggy and haggard. His hair was weirdly unkempt. Even he had no idea what had happened to his appearance... nor did he care. His physical presentation was the last thing on his mind.

Daisy's eyes fluttered open. The pain from the operation had already faded into background noise.

"Uhhhnn... it's over, dad?" Daisy asked, looking blankly up at the ceiling. "I don't... feel... any different."

She hadn't noticed her father's appearance yet. Jason had taken several steps backward to try and collect himself, but he wasn't having much success. "It... um... it..."

"The MindCore isn't active yet." Nadia jumped in, seeing the look on Jason's face. She drew Daisy's attention to herself, giving Jason a moment to turn around and quietly use Wordsmithing to clean himself up. "Part of the v4 installation procedure is making sure it remains inert until we turn it on. Otherwise, what if what happened to me happened to you? We'd prefer not to trap you in a multi-decade simulation."

"Oh... that makes sense." Daisy said quietly. She slowly blinked her eyes, feeling quite fatigued. "Is it safe, then? Safe to turn on...?"

Nadia looked back at Jason, behind Daisy's operation chair. He turned around, looking refreshed. With the power of Wordsmithing, he'd quickly cleaned himself up, but Nadia could tell there was a jerkiness to his movements that wasn't there before.

"We can turn it on... sweetheart." Jason said gently.

He stepped toward Daisy, then leaned over her head. He looked down into his daughter's eyes, and she looked up at him for the first time.

"Dad? Are you okay?" Daisy asked.

"Yeah... it was a tiring procedure." Jason said through gritted teeth. "What was it like for you?"

Daisy pondered the question. "I don't know. I felt this pain... and warmth... it went back and forth. I could feel something happening... but then it was all over. I don't know why I'm so tired. You had to do all the work."

Jason quietly exhaled in relief. It was possible Daisy was lying, but he felt she was telling the truth.

What he'd witnessed... only he had seen. She hadn't been forced to relive her worst traumas.

"That's good, baby." Jason said, leaning over to kiss Daisy's forehead. "I'm glad you ended up okay, honey."

Daisy squinted. Her dad seemed softer and more loving now, but she couldn't put a finger on why. "You sure you're okay, dad? You can rest if you need to."

"I'll rest when I'm dead." Jason joked. He rustled Daisy's hair playfully, but Daisy felt the action was rather forced.

She could tell something was bothering her father, but she was too tired from the surgery to give it much thought. On top of that, her heart had butterflies now that she was thinking about the inevitable activation of her new MindCore.

Nadia helped Daisy stand up. Daisy rose to her feet shakily, feeling quite weak compared to her usual self.

"The new operation procedures reduce a lot of the pain and risk by making sure the MindCore is inert and deactivated during and after the surgery." Nadia explained. "We're not going to activate your new MindCore just yet. Instead, I'll take you back home, and you get some rest first. A good eight hours of sleep should do."

"But..." Daisy started to protest.

"No 'buts', young lady." Nadia chided. "Sleep first, fun new toy later."

"Yes, *mom*." Daisy said, sticking her tongue out at Nadia playfully.

Nadia smiled, but the fact Daisy referred to her as a mother also made her heart skip a beat for some indiscernible reason.

She led Daisy home and helped her into bed. Then she made her way back to the operation room where she found Jason laying on a couch in the back of the room. He was flopped onto his back, a cold washrag covering his face.

Nadia approached. She stopped a short distance away and crossed her arms.

"What did you see?" Nadia asked.

"Nothing." Jason mumbled.

"Don't lie to me. I observed several telepathic activity spikes during the surgery. Daisy must have been sending you mental images." Nadia said.

Neither person said anything for a short while. Jason eventually reached up and pulled the washrag off his face. He turned his eyes to the right to look at Nadia.

"It was her childhood." Jason said quietly. "I saw... terrible things."

"I thought so." Nadia said with a nod. "It's not too different from what happened with you and I, except instead of me downloading your memory-copy, you accidentally received telepathic images of Daisy's youth. The feedback loop was reversed due to the structural differences between v3 and v4."

"Cool." Jason grumbled, putting the washcloth back over his face.

Another long silence followed. Nadia sat down in front of the couch, facing Jason as she looked up at him from her spot on the floor.

"Do you want to talk about what you saw?" Nadia asked.

Jason didn't answer immediately.

He thought for a while, debating what exactly he wanted to do with this new information.

He couldn't just let it go. As a father and a man, he could have simply played stupid before, merely comforting his little girl if she mentioned her past. But now that he had the closest equivalent to firsthand experience with it, he felt he couldn't just sit idly by and do nothing. He had to be proactive. He *wanted* to be.

"I want..." Jason said softly. "...I want you... to go to the Spynet... and use all Aevum's resources to find the names and locations of several men and women. I only have visual images of them. I don't know their identities."

"Show me." Nadia said.

And so he did. Jason reached out a finger without looking, and Nadia touched her finger to his. Jason transmitted the faces of several Russian scientists to her. She crinkled her nose a few times.

"I don't know any of them. But I can find out who they are. Are they still alive?"

"No idea." Jason said. "They'd better hope they're not. I *pray* they are."

"Alright." Nadia said.

She stood up. She created facsimiles of the faces and appearances of the people Jason had given her, rebuilding them inside her RealitySim. Thankfully, Jason's memories,

taken from Daisy, had also included representations of their manner of speech, their voices, their actions, and their personalities.

That would make it far easier to uncover who they were.

"You rest. I'll get to work." Nadia said, as she turned and left the room.

The door slammed shut behind her, and the medical facility fell silent, leaving Jason alone with his thoughts.

"...This place is so fucking cursed." Jason grumbled, as he realized three people had now been traumatized inside the surgery room.

Maybe MindCores were more of a pain than they were worth.

Part 775: Awakened

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Daisy slept like a baby. As soon as her head hit the pillow, it was lights-out, her brain spinning and whirling around at a speed so slow it felt like months passed. Her dreams were vivid but bizarre.

She somehow lived short lives of countless animals, large and small. The world distorted around her as she imagined herself crawling on tree trunks, swinging through the branches, flying through the air, swimming beneath the oceans, tracking prey, hiding and fleeing from predators, and countless other scenarios.

Her sleep was peaceful. It was exciting. She experienced dreams unlike any she had before, ones which sometimes left her heart racing in exhilaration and other times made her curl into a ball of fear.

Eventually, the dreams came to a close. Daisy awoke feeling like she was sleeping in a tropical swamp. Her entire body felt hotter than usual, and when she started to lift her head off the pillow, she felt the fabric sticking to her face.

"Huhhh...?" Daisy slurred. "Drool? I... *drooledinmysleep*?"

She was disgusted and mortified. Her pillow was caked in slobber. If she had a roommate or a boyfriend, she'd probably want to crawl into a hole and die from shame right then and there. She moved her arm to peel the pillowcase off her face, but her arm felt wet and gross too.

She then realized that she'd perspired like an insane woman all night long. Her entire bed was drenched in sweat, as if she'd been sprayed with a fire-hose. As soon as she pulled the covers off, she felt a chill from the slight movement of the air in the room. Just what the hell had she been dreaming about to cause such a weird reaction in her body?!

As soon as she tried to recall them, the memories of her dreams faded away. She sat up in bed and rubbed her eyes. She felt more well-rested than at any other point in her life, yet she also still felt lethargic and ready to go right back to sleep. It was a sensation she wasn't familiar with.

Daisy's eyes drifted to the clock on her wall. It showed it was almost 2 PM. And she had gone to sleep at 6 PM... the day before!

"I slept... that long?" Daisy asked nobody in particular. "Geez..."

She dragged herself out of bed, peeled her water-logged clothes off, and stumbled into the shower. As soon as the hot water streaked down her skin, she started to wake up, like a cold-blooded reptile awoken by the warmth of the midday sun. Before long, she had become fully alert, and she started to whistle a random song in the shower. The odd part was, she kept making strange bird noises with zero effort. She even found it easy to chirp like a songbird or caw like a crow.

"Is this the effect of my MindCore?" Daisy eventually wondered. "But dad said it wasn't turned on yet..."

Daisy brushed her teeth after showering. She quickly yanked all her bedding off and threw it in a special laundry machine her father had designed. It could wash a load in only five minutes, then dry it in five minutes as well. While she waited, Daisy started doing her morning stretches just to limber up for the day.

This, at the least, felt normal. She didn't sense that her movements were all that different from the usual, except that maybe her sense of balance seemed slightly better than before... but that could have been a placebo.

She pulled her bedding from the dryer, made her bed, then put on a blue and yellow training outfit. She had a feeling this would be a busy day, once her father turned on the MindCore for real. Secretly, she wondered if he'd screwed up again and it was already active.

Daisy teleported out of her room, arriving inside the medical facility. Less than five seconds after she arrived, her father popped in.

"Hey, sweetie!" Jason said with a smile. "Did you sleep well? You were down for so long I started to get worried."

"Sorry, dad." Daisy said, blushing out of embarrassment. "I, um, I did sleep a lot. But everything seems to have gone fine. I think I had some weird dreams though."

"Weird dreams?" Jason asked, his voice rising an octave. The blood drained from his face as a look of barely concealed fear washed over him. "L-like what, exactly?!"

"No, no, dad. It's not like, um, Nadia's situation." Daisy quickly explained. "They were just a little strange, is all. I can't even remember what they were."

"Oh... oh, okay. That's good then." Jason said, nervously smiling again. "Well, let's hurry up and get you checked out."

Ten minutes later, Nadia arrived, having been called over by Jason. When she entered, she and Jason started talking to Daisy about the surgery, and assessed her current condition as well.

"So, a copious amount of sweating while you were sleeping?" Nadia asked, her tone tinged with slight concern. "There shouldn't have been any major effects like that..."

"It scared me a little when I woke up, and it was um... pretty embarrassing." Daisy admitted. "But I thought it might be important for you to know."

"At the very least, it doesn't seem like you suffered any crazy mental or physical trauma." Nadia said with a nod, her expression becoming more relaxed. "We built you an entire Mind Realm from scratch. Even if we kept it turned off, I'm not surprised there were at least a few small side effects."

Jason used his Wordsmithing to look at Daisy's MindCore from the outside. By this point, her spirituality had been solidified to the point now that even with his Wordsmithing he could no longer forcibly intrude into the deepest recesses of her mind. He could only observe it from the outside.

"Uh oh." Jason said, causing Daisy to jump in alarm.

"Uh oh?!" Daisy repeated, looking at her father in alarm.

"I, ah, sorry. It's just... well, it seems a tiny part of your MindCore either wasn't deactivated like I expected, or it got turned on somehow. Either way... that explains the animal noises. Looks like maybe 0.01% of the MindCore was active last night. Goodness..."

Jason looked at Nadia. She nodded at him. That seemed to confirm something, so he returned his gaze to Daisy.

"Alright. I think it's time we turned this thing on. Not all at once, just a little bit at a time. Let's start by turning on your entire MindCore, but only at 1% power."

Daisy nodded. She had butterflies in her stomach due to anticipation and anxiety, but she wasn't a quitter, and she wouldn't back down once she made a decision.

She closed her eyes and waited as her father guided her through the process of turning on her MindCore. Daisy had no idea how to interact with it at first, but under his expert guidance, he was able to enter her MindCore along with a soul avatar of herself. They arrived outside the confines of a massive planet ten times the size of Earth. The two of them levitated in space, looking down on the super-massive world which should have bone-crushing gravity compared to Earth, but inside Daisy's Mind Realm, felt completely comfortable for her to drop down on and walk around.

The world was covered in diverse biomes. Oceans deeper than the ones on Earth, forests with trees the size of Earth's mountains, countless alien bugs and animals skittering and racing across the surface. Under Daisy's direction, the power of her 'planet' became active, and the life on it grew noticeably more energetic. Even viewed from outer space, she 'felt' the world come to life, and it sparked feelings of awe in her heart.

The two of them descended. They arrived on an alien world as different from Earth as Aevum was, with all its strange wildlife and other such things.

"There are many creatures on this world taken directly from Earth, but I didn't limit my horizons only to Earth." Jason explained to his daughter. "There are countless monster species referenced, as well as animals from Tarus II and other worlds I've visited. What makes the QuantumReflex special is that you will develop a powerful affinity to all forms of life, sentient and non-sentient alike. By observing them, you'll be able to learn how they live and adapt whatever you like about them into yourself."

"Are you saying I can transform into animals now?" Daisy asked.

"No, not at all." Jason said. "But animal instincts and knowledge and abilities, especially mental aspects, will become yours to control. Even I don't know how far that will take you."

He paused.

"Though now that you mention it, this MindCore would be great for Belial. Shame she's our enemy right now..."

"Aunt Samantha." Daisy muttered.

She could barely remember her aunt. It had been so many years, she only remembered Samantha's smile, and the way she could change faces to cheer Daisy up when she was crying. The rest of Daisy's memories were a blur at best.

"Anyway, let's focus on your MindCore." Jason said, breaking the spell. "Tell me about what you're feeling. Are you overwhelmed?"

"No... I feel... fine." Daisy said hesitantly. She looked down at her hands and arms, and they did feel slightly tingly, but that feeling faded after a while. "Let's activate the MindCore more fully."

"Okay. Let's increase it from 1% power to 5%." Jason suggested.

Like this, Jason slowly dialed up the power of Daisy's MindCore, bit by bit. Once they reached 20%, Daisy started to feel strange, *very* strange indeed.

"It's not bad..." Daisy said, "but I think I'm... I don't know. Let's return to the real world."

At her request, they did. When they opened their eyes back in the surgical ward, Nadia noticed immediately.

"My PepScan is picking up elevated brain energy levels." She said, holding up a small scanning device in her hand. She moved it toward the side of Daisy's head. "Looks like you turned on the MindCore with no adverse-"

Suddenly, Daisy's eyes snapped toward the beeping scanner in Nadia's hand.

DANGER!

Her instincts screamed a warning at her. Daisy quickly turned her body and recoiled from Nadia's hand. Before anyone could react, she launched a backhanded slap upward and sent the scanning tool flying out of Nadia's grasp, battering her entire arm out of the way and causing her to awkwardly tumble to the ground.

"Daisy! Nadia!" Jason exclaimed, the unexpected attack from his daughter startling him. He took a step toward Daisy, and her pupils shrunk to pinpricks.

DANGER!

She immediately sensed a threat coming from her father. Without conscious thought, Daisy quickly sprung out of the chair with catlike agility, swept her leg at Jason's feet to knock him off-balance, then thrust a palm at his chest. She struck her dad in the sternum and sent him fumbling backward, where he fell on his ass!

Jason and Nadia, both completely caught off-guard, fell to the ground and looked up at her in shock! Daisy's eyes reverted to normal, and her perceptions suddenly caught up

to that instant in time.

"Ah-ahh!" Daisy cried. "D-dad, Nadia! I, I didn't mean to, oh my god! Are you both okay?!"

Nadia stood up and took a few steps back from Daisy. "I'm fine. Good... reflexes."

Jason coughed. Daisy's palm-strike hadn't carried any lethal force, it was a purely defensive move. Even so, he needed a Word of Power to soothe the mild pain he was feeling and restore the wind she'd driven from his chest.

"Well... that was a little... unexpected." Jason coughed.

He also stood back up. An odd atmosphere fell upon the room as he and Nadia observed Daisy once more, but this time from a safe distance.

"I don't know what happened." Daisy said, feeling a cold chill wash over her skin. "I just... felt like my life was in danger, and I reacted."

"That's obviously your MindCore showing its value." Jason said, massaging his chest. "Don't worry about it, honey. I'm resilient, and you didn't hurt Nadia. We expected something like this might happen. Dial your MindCore back down, and let's go to the training area to adjust you to your new normal slowly, rather than spiking your cortisol levels all at once."

"That's a good idea." Daisy said, smiling.

She felt a bit of guilt at attacking her father and Nadia like that, but she also knew it wasn't her fault. No real harm was done.

The trio departed, teleporting into the gymnasium where the other teenagers were currently training. As always, Jerome was pumping weights like crazy, using specialized equipment Jason had built that could exert multiple tons of weight onto specific muscles in Jerome's body to give him a full-body workout. Phoebe was there, too. She was running through an obstacle course, jumping over barriers, sliding between gaps in walls, climbing slopes, and doing other such things to hone her agility.

Sasha was also there, but she was mainly using her powers to make clothes atop a table that Marco and Brian were also sitting at. She really liked spending most of her time working on fashion. Jason thought it was a bit of a problem, but until she had a MindCore, he wasn't going to push her too hard.

Marco was... not doing much of anything. He and Brian were sitting together, playing cards off in the corner. Neither of them were particularly diligent about training their abilities. They yapped with Sasha while she tailored, and it was clear at a glance the trio were the laziest members of the youths Jason had brought. There was no urgency in their movements.

Jason didn't see Farrah at all, but he knew she was training her newfound shapeshifting abilities harder than before. She simply got embarrassed easily, and thus she didn't like to body-shift in front of other people.

"Jerome!" Jason said as they arrived. "Daisy just got her new MindCore. Would you mind sparring with her for a bit? Just *light* sparring. Nothing crazy."

Jerome grunted loudly as he benched five and a half tons of Wordsmithium-based dumbbells. He hoisted the heavy metal up and set it back on the bars.

"Sounds good, boss." Jerome said, wiping the sweat from his brow. "Just gimme a minute to clean up. I'm sweating like a motherfucker here."

Usually, Farrah would be hanging out with Jerome while he bench-pressed, giving him water and wiping off his sweat for him. She was a very supportive girlfriend in that regard, but ever since Jason talked to her, she'd been spending more time by herself.

Thus, Jerome had to take a few minutes to steady his breathing and cool the fire in his lungs. He grabbed a towel and mopped his face and neck before grabbing a sports drink and chugging half a liter of it in seconds.

Once he had recovered, Jerome hopped onto the sparring stage. A fight between him and Daisy was always the highlight of any day, so everyone dropped what they were doing and ran over to sit beside the stage. It wasn't a secret Daisy's MindCore was supposed to be installed the day before, so it seemed likely the surgery must have been a success. With only Jason, Nadia, and the Daughter of Heaven as examples, people still weren't entirely sure just how formidable MindCores were.

Catherine hadn't trained much with the humans. Jason was always busy with his Trueborn stuff, and Nadia wasn't a fighter. Thus, the effects of a MindCore on someone's combat capabilities were essentially unknown.

"Do you think Daisy is going to win?" Brian asked Marco as they walked over.

"Well, she already beat Jerome pretty handily before." Marco replied. "Jerome's been training a lot though, and he's way stronger than in the past. I guess it depends on if the brain-juicer makes her a better fighter...?"

"Seems her win is a foregone conclusion." Brian mused. "Let's just watch and see what happens."

The two of them sat down with the rest. Daisy hopped in the sparring ring and started bouncing lightly on her toes, a noticeable spring now in her step. Daisy had always been more agile than she was physically imposing, but now she seemed even lighter on her feet than before.

Jerome, meanwhile, simply assumed a forward-facing horse-stance with both fists raised. His expression was solemn. He'd already gotten his ass kicked several times by Daisy, and he'd never won a proper fight once she had gone all-out.

"No powers, no magic." Daisy said, her eye slightly twitching. "Let's do Sport Jujitsu rules."

"Jujitsu?" Jerome repeated, slightly bewildered.

This was a special type of sparring that was done more for sport and for reflex or body training than for maximizing damage. It involved light contact, no strikes to the face, no knockout punches, but take-downs were allowed with the goal of pinning the opponent to the mat or locking their movements with grapples. It was also the type of sparring he completely dominated her in. His strength was way higher than hers, especially after his recent training sessions. His body was tougher too, and he could take more abuse than before without even breaking his skin. He was damn-near bulletproof, at least to small-arms fire.

"You sure?" Jerome asked carefully.

"I want to know what I'm capable of." Daisy said, her tone fearless.

"Suit yourself." Jerome concluded.

Without any smack-talk, the two launched at each other. Jerome grabbed at Daisy, but her movements were noticeably snappier and more responsive than before. His giant hand grabbed at her throat, but she side-stepped, allowing his thumb to barely brush her neck as she darted around him and grabbed for his waist.

Jerome turned. He sent a palm strike at Daisy's shoulder to try and knock her off her feet, but she twisted her body at a weird angle. His palm once again missed the mark. She was forced to take a few quick steps backward as Jerome made three more attempts to pin her down and stop her from zipping to his sides.

Jerome seemed slow and clumsy compared to Daisy. Indeed, this was his biggest weakness in a battle among superior mortals. Against an ordinary human, even a professional MMA fighter, his movements would be extremely fast and fearsome. It was just that to Daisy, her newly enhanced brain processed information at an accelerated rate. She was easily able to outpace Jerome.

However, that was the extent of it. Daisy avoided getting grabbed, but she couldn't get close enough to Jerome to tackle him to the floor either. Eventually, she slipped up. Jerome's superior endurance made him outlast her by a substantial margin. Just when she was starting to get winded from going full-force with him for three minutes straight, Jerome finally pounced, grabbed both her shoulders, and threw her to the mat. It wasn't the most elegant win, but a point was a point.

Once Jerome grabbed Daisy, that was basically the end. Relying purely on her physical body, she was no match for him. It was like watching a heavyweight champion 'wrestle' a toddler. Daisy had only beaten him handily in the past by relying on her metaphysical powers. If she deliberately didn't use them, she lasted only a little longer than an ordinary human would against Jerome.

"Haha! Not bad!" Jerome said, standing up. "You're faster than before, and you react quicker, too!"

Jerome felt pretty good. He knew he couldn't 'really' beat Daisy, but at least if she didn't use her powers, he could eke out a win. The same wasn't true of her old man. Jason still handed Jerome his ass when they physically sparred, assuming Jason was allowed to wield a bo staff.

"Oh, Jerome!" Jason called out from the side of the arena. "The session's not done."

"Really?" Jerome asked. "What, we're doing multiple points this time?"

"No, well, I mean, yes." Jason answered confusingly. "It's just, Daisy's operation is complete and she has her new MindCore... but we currently only have it set to five percent power. Now I'll dial it up, and you'll try again."

Jerome blinked. "What? Five percent? She's this much faster, and that's only with her new brain-thingy at five percent??"

Daisy hopped to her feet and dusted off her shoulders. "Yup."

Jerome scrunched up his face. He looked Daisy up and down again. She'd certainly started moving a lot faster, but it wasn't anything he couldn't handle. Even if she became even faster than now, he'd still have the overwhelming advantage. Did the Archseer really think her MindCore would let her beat someone as strong as Jerome?

"Aight, let's catch our breath and go again in ten minutes." Jerome said, walking over to grab his sports drink. He started chugging it again, then sat down and relaxed, letting his heart rate drop back to normal.

Daisy mimicked him and took some time to relax her muscles. She did as her father asked and raised the QuantumReflex's power level from 5% to 10%. She looked out the window and sniffed the air. It seemed she'd caught the scent of cookies from off in the distance.

Jerome cracked his neck. The minutes passed by quickly, and eventually the two of them hopped back in the arena.

"My MindCore power level has doubled since we last sparred." Daisy warned Jerome.

"Twice the brains, still gonna lose." Jerome quipped.

He was a little nervous, mainly because he didn't want to underestimate her, but at the same time, Jerome was confident in his own abilities.

If Daisy didn't use her powers, Jerome was certain he was the top dog among Aevum's Heroes.

Could her MindCore really bridge the gap?

Jason made a chopping motion with the side of his hand.

"Round two, start!"

Part 776: Getting Clapped

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Daisy and Jerome took up their positions once more. The tiny crowd of onlookers whispered among each other, with the teens on one side of the stage, while Jason and Nadia were on the other. Phoebe also came over to join them, looking at the young man and woman on the stage with interest.

Jason made a chopping motion with the side of his hand.

"Round two, start!"

Daisy was the first to move. After suffering a loss in the previous round, she was eager to remind everyone that she was stronger than Jerome. Her father was the top dog in Aevum, and her mother was a bonafide badass too! As one of two Trueborn on the scene, Daisy couldn't allow herself to lose to a Lowborn. It simply wasn't right!

Daisy's MindCore was increased to 10% potency, up from 5%. This meant that functionally speaking, the effects of her MindCore were doubled compared to the previous round.

She charged at Jerome, then abruptly stepped to the side before he could even move. Jerome's hand grabbed at the spot where she had been about to stand, the side-step completely throwing him off. He quickly rotated his palm to slap toward her new position, but Daisy was already ducking again, causing him to whiff the attack.

Jerome was not an idiot, and he had a lot of combat experience, easily comparable to Daisy herself. He had never taken a life, unlike her, so he didn't have a trained bloodthirstiness burned into his bones, but the Illuminati had gone to a lot of trouble to train him for the entire year he'd been with them, from ages 17 to 18.

Thus, despite Daisy's spike in combat capabilities, Jerome adapted.

Daisy moved faster than before. She dodged attacks that Jerome hadn't even launched yet. He countered by mixing more feints into his arsenal.

Jerome twitched his body, retracting his right shoulder as if about to wind up a punch. Daisy dodged the incoming punch, only for his left hand to snap out and grab at her face. She dodged that too, but with way less leeway than originally planned.

Daisy continued to dog Jerome, dodging one attack after another, but she became continuously more and more frustrated by the fact that even if she was able to dodge him, he was moving a lot less than her, expending less energy over time, and relying heavily on his enhanced endurance.

Just like the first round, Daisy started to pant like a dog in a hot car. Her lungs burned as she tried to stay ahead of Jerome, while all he did was breathe a little harder than before. Daisy eventually seized an opening. She slithered around Jerome and grabbed his waist from behind to try and throw him to the floor, but his hand slapped the side of her head and sent her sprawling. When Daisy struck the ground, it took her a couple of seconds to shake off the slap and clamber back to her feet. Jerome didn't even make a move to pin her down.

Within three minutes, Daisy had once again completely run out of gas. She started coughing and wheezing, and her vision went blurry from lack of oxygen to her brain. Another light slap from Jerome left her in a heap, and this time, she didn't even try to get up. Her legs were on fire, and they started shaking from overwhelming adrenaline.

Jerome knelt beside her and put a palm on her back to pin her in place. She didn't have the strength to stop him, so round two was her loss as well.

After a few minutes of chugging sports drinks and wheezing out the fire in her lungs, a teary-eyed Daisy managed to climb back to her feet, but she looked way worse for wear. Two back to back losses had already started to grind her down.

Jerome didn't mock her. He knew that if she used all her powers, she'd lay him out in seconds. He found it admirable she was pushing her physical body to its limits. After all, wasn't that what he did every single day? There was no disrespect in his eyes.

"You rely on your powers a lot." Jerome remarked. "You ain't used to usin' your raw physicality. Yeah, you're movin' too fast for me to land a solid hit, but you're also blowing too much steam to dodge me. I can just stand in place and let you dance til your legs start shakin'. It's over after that."

Daisy grimaced. She lowered her eyes, feeling slightly humiliated. She knew Jerome was a big tough guy and all that, but there was no hatred or mockery in his words. Sure, he could be arrogant and prideful, but he loved fighting and he was genuinely trying to help her out.

That didn't change the fact she'd lost twice. She still felt humiliated because of her own inadequacy.

"I'm going to... raise my MindCore... to 20% this time." Daisy said through choked breaths. "I'll keep in mind what you said."

Round 3 began far less explosively than round 2. Everyone present now knew of Jason's general powers, so he didn't hold back in restoring Daisy and Jerome's stamina. Almost everyone still knew Jason as the 'Archseer' but even the dullest-witted or least observant among them would have had to be truly stupid to not notice Jason's powers going way above and beyond that of a mere 'dream eater'.

While his identity as the Wordsmith was not directly known, it was practically a given that all the teenagers knew he was the true architect of Aevum. Their respect and admiration for him had only grown fiercer as time passed. The fact he looked like a teenager meant nothing, because he carried himself as a proper elder would. It was obvious he was not some immature youngster, lacking in wisdom.

With their stamina and bodies restored, Daisy and Jerome launched toward each other, initiating another fast-paced sparring match. This time, Daisy focused less on using full-body movements to dodge Jerome, but instead used smaller evasive maneuvers to make him miss by tinier thresholds.

Immediately, there was a big improvement compared to her first two rounds. Daisy conserved more energy and didn't get winded nearly as fast. Jerome managed to slap her a couple of times, taking care to hold back his strength and not injure her. If she were using her powers, he'd definitely be the one running out of gas as he struck with his full power. Even so, despite landing a few blows, Daisy managed to remain on her feet for nearly six full minutes.

Eventually, she lost again. The margin of victory for Jerome was growing thinner and thinner, and he was now starting to see the advantages her MindCore provided.

"We'll increase your MindCore to 50% power." Jason said, after he and Nadia deliberated for a while.

Round 3 had ended with his little girl's loss, and even Jason was starting to feel bad for her. This was not how he anticipated the MindCore's effectiveness playing out. Even at a mere 20% power, she should be several times more intelligent and fast-reacting than before. Maybe 50% would provide a serious boost?

Daisy nodded. "Okay, dad. If I still lose, I'll be too embarrassed to even think of fighting Jerome at 100% power."

Under Jason's guidance, Daisy raised the energy coursing through her MindCore until it reached 50% saturation. This forced her to take several minutes to adjust.

Daisy felt like a limiter had broken. She looked around the room and noticed countless details that made the hair stand up on her body in alarm. There were bugs crawling on the walls she hadn't noticed before, a bird that was perched outside one of the windows, looking down at the teenagers with mild interest. She smelled the sweat on Jerome's body, which caused her vision to waver, slightly. He smelled oddly *nice* in a way she couldn't verbalize.

Daisy stepped into the arena again. As Jerome approached, his scent grew more overpowering, more intoxicating. Daisy's pupils dilated slightly as her eyes were drawn to the curvature of his muscles, the slickness of sweat on his forehead, even the muskiness of his hair. She felt an odd 'craving' somewhere in her body she hadn't experienced before, her mind conjuring images of Jerome pouncing on her, pinning her to the ground, and holding her down while she cried out in protest, yet eventually succumbing to his manly-

Daisy quickly blinked her eyes and looked away, blushing madly while feeling slightly flustered. *What the hell was that?*

Was she a goddamn animal? Jerome was obviously spoken for and had a girlfriend. Daisy was an intelligent young woman, not a freaking cat in heat. She had no idea where these weird feelings had sprung from, but the culprit seemed to be her MindCore.

She smacked the side of her head to try and get her mind back in focus, and this motion made Jerome and the others raise their eyebrows. There was a stilted oddness to Daisy's movements, but nobody could quite put their finger on what that oddity *was*.

"Round 4, start!" Jason shouted, making a chopping motion with his palm.

Daisy's eyes narrowed. She lunged at Jerome like before, and he took a step back to try and swat her away, like he had several times now.

But this time, Daisy didn't just passively dodge his slap. Instead, she pulled back, allowed his palm to pass the spot where her face would have been, then she deliberately struck the back of his hand, increasing his momentum and making him swing harder than he intended.

Like this, Jerome's balance was thrown off! His casual slap abruptly accelerated halfway, and this caused him to stumble forward a couple of steps. He recovered, only to see Daisy springing off her hands and sending a foot flying at his face.

Thunk!

Her kick slammed into his jaw and spun his head, jarring Jerome's senses. He completely lost his footing and fell to the side, hitting the ground with a hard impact.

Jerome landed on his shoulder and grunted. He wasn't hurt. Daisy's strongest physical attack, lacking any magic to enhance it, would never be able to cause him serious injury unless she were stabbing a finger into his eye or something. A kick to the chin only jarred his brain and turned his vision blurry for a second.

He quickly shook off his dizziness, then started to climb to his feet. But Daisy wasn't in front of him anymore.

Just as Jerome was about to look for his opponent, two palms clapped on both his ears, blasting his head with pain. Jerome cried out and fell to the floor, cupping the sides of his head as stars danced in his eyes and a screeching sound erupted inside his head. He felt Daisy climb on top of him to pin him down, but he was in such pain that he needed several seconds before he could open his teary eyes.

When Jerome finally recovered, he was still dizzy and nauseous. Clapping someone's ears was an extremely effective tactic that bypassed even Jerome's defenses and endurance. It directly crippled him and left him vulnerable on the ground.

"Sorry." Daisy said, as she tried to help Jerome to his feet. "That was a dirty tactic."

"Yeah. Bitch move." Jerome hissed through gritted teeth, shaking Daisy's grip off his arm. He shot her a nasty glare. "That fucking hurt like hell!"

Jason intervened to heal Jerome's ears, but it was clear the teenager was pissed about Daisy clapping his head like that. The first kick to his chin wasn't bad, he would have accepted it. But the double-ear clap was a scummy move that only worked because he was momentarily incapacitated.

Daisy was happy because a win was a win. But she also believed she hadn't really earned the victory, and the fact she'd hurt Jerome sent her emotions into turmoil. Thus, instead of increasing her MindCore another level, she kept it at 50% for the next fight.

They began Round 5 similarly to Round 4. This time though, Jerome's expression was noticeably more menacing. His movements became more focused, and he looked at Daisy with visible anger in his eyes.

Daisy's skin prickled. For the first time, Jerome rushed at her from the start of the round, and something screamed in the back of her mind.

DANGER!

She moved without intending. Jerome's slap careened toward her much faster than before, with a lot more force put behind it. Daisy dodged the slap, her heart racing.

He was *truly* enraged. He was out for blood. Jerome usually respected other people in fights and tried not to go too hard on them, but in his mind, Daisy's clap had been an act of cowardice, and that had sent him over the edge.

He slapped again, and again. Daisy was forced on her back-foot, her danger sense roaring in the back of her mind like a rabbit fearing the snapping jaws of a hungry mountain lion.

Jason narrowed his eyes. He watched from the sidelines, frowning as he easily picked up on the bloodlust in Jerome's movements. Immediately, Jason's protective fatherly instincts flared up. He took a step forward, but Phoebe grabbed him by the back of his collar.

"No." Phoebe said, restraining Jason. "Don't interfere."

Jason pulled his gaze away from the anxiety-inducing fight to glower at Phoebe. His expression softened, because he couldn't stay angry at his 'wife' for any length of time. "Why are you stopping me?"

"Because Jerome is still holding back." Phoebe said. "He's just holding back a lot *less* than he was before."

Jerome started slapping at Daisy faster and faster. He stomped the ground, causing the arena to buckle and her to nearly lose her footing. A lesser combatant certainly would have, but Daisy's MindCore sped her mind up and granted her catlike reflexes. When she lost her footing and started to fall, she simply turned in midair, planted her palms on the ground, and lowered herself back into a crouch.

A furious melee followed. Jerome started chasing Daisy around the arena, slapping toward her with enough strength to shatter concrete walls. Each time Daisy dodged, she

kept her movements to a minimum. Her animal instincts grew stronger every second the fight continued. Jerome clawed toward her chest with his fingernails, a move that might rip the skin off her bones, but she only allowed herself to pull back with an inch or two to spare.

Just when Daisy thought she had an opening, Jerome revealed a secret move he hadn't used before. He violently clapped his palms in front of himself with his full strength, causing a shockwave to fire out, slam into Daisy, and send her flying! Daisy spun through the air, twisted her body, and landed on her hands and feet like a cat would.

"Ring out!" Jason shouted.

Jerome took two steps toward Daisy, as if barely containing his anger and still wanting to slap the teeth out of her mouth, but when Jason's words registered, he slowed his momentum and came to a stop.

Daisy's ears were ringing now. She and everyone else experienced the pain of Jerome's 'Thunder Clap', but it wasn't nearly as strong as one Bael or another mighty entity might perform. Daisy gritted her teeth, feeling her proprioception thrown off. Little did she know that her father explicitly called ring-out in order to end the fight because he was worried about the anger Jerome was displaying.

"Jerome!" Jason said, quickly stepping between his daughter and her opponent. "You need to calm down. You're flying out of control!"

"Oh, now daddy has to step in huh?" Jerome spat. "Your little bitch of a daughter nearly blew my fuckin' eardrums out!"

"I said I was sorry!" Daisy replied, rising to her feet.

"Oh, and that makes it okay?! Just try to hurt someone for real in a sparring match, but if you apologize it's all good?!" Jerome argued.

A moment of silence followed. Jerome directed a nasty look Daisy's way, and she lowered her eyes, wanting to defend herself, but also feeling guilty about what she'd done.

"I'm sorry, okay?" Daisy said, lowering her voice. "I don't know what came over me. Maybe it was my MindCore. I just really wanted to win and... I don't know."

Jerome licked his lips. He was still pissed, and he looked like he wanted to say something, but ultimately, he decided not to. He turned around and stormed away.

"Whatever! Go play with yourself then, arrogant bitch! I'm done with you!"

"Hey! Jerome, hey! Young man, I'm talking to you!" Jason shouted at Jerome's back.

"Fuck off!" Jerome roared back. "Miss me with that 'old man Jason' bullshit! I ain't in the mood for you!"

He didn't even look backward. He simply kept storming forward until he left the gymnasium, slamming the door hard enough to break the frame.

After the thunderous exit, the entire room went quiet for a while.

"Dad..." Daisy whispered. "I... I didn't mean to. I feel so bad but like... I don't know... what do I do?"

"I know you didn't, baby." Jason said, turning around to smile consolingly at her. "He's mad, but that's okay. It's better he gets it out of his system."

"I screwed everything up." Daisy mumbled, feeling completely dispirited. "So much for testing my new MindCore."

"Why don't you spar with me?" Phoebe asked, stepping forward. She smiled gently at Daisy. "Don't let Jerome get you down. You couldn't make up the size and power gap between the two of you, which forced you to use a cheap trick. I'll make a better opponent for you than he was."

Daisy's eyes brightened. "Really, mo- uh, Miss Berthold? You'd do that for me?"

Phoebe noticed that Daisy had almost called her 'mom' again, but she pretended not to hear. "Of course. I watched your fight, and I think you might make a good sparring partner for me as well. Let's give it a shot."

Daisy bobbed her head up and down excitedly, her momentary depression vanishing into the wind. She still felt bad about Jerome, but ultimately he was just 'some guy' she'd only known a couple of weeks. Compared to getting to spend time with her mother, his anger left little impact on her psyche.

It might seem selfish to some people, especially Jerome's friends, but Daisy was only 18, and another 18-year-old holding a grudge didn't matter much to her.

Daisy hopped back up, unable to stop herself from smiling ear to ear. She jumped into the arena and raised her fists, while Phoebe casually walked over and stood in place, resting her hands on her hips.

"Your new MindCore sounds interesting." Phoebe said. "Why don't you raise its power right to 100%?"

Daisy's smile faltered. She was taken aback. "S-seriously? I don't know... that sounds dangerous. I wouldn't want to hurt you."

"I was one of King Arthur's knights." Phoebe said. A hint of arrogance flashed in her eyes. "My mentor taught me well. If I lose to a little girl, then that merely proves I need more training."

Jason slightly frowned. Phoebe's attitude lately was starting to feel drastically different from the one he knew. Of course, 'his' Phoebe would never talk to their daughter that way, and obviously this Phoebe was not Daisy's mother. But even so, talking down to a teenager like that just wasn't something Phoebe would do.

Daisy didn't even notice the arrogance in her mother's words. Rather, she recalled the last time she got her ass handed to her when she sparred with Phoebe, as well as the thought that Phoebe was way stronger than her. It was only natural her mother would be so arrogant! Clearly this was why her father had fallen in love with her mother. Phoebe was just that much of a badass!

Thus, the misunderstanding persisted and was amplified even further.

Phoebe grabbed the 'Noodle Swords' from before and tossed one over to Daisy. "Show me how much you've improved."

Daisy caught the weapon with much greater ease than before. "I won't use my abilities this time. Only my MindCore."

"That's not necessary." Phoebe said with a smile. "You can go all-out."

"It is necessary. I want to see what my mind and body alone can do." Daisy retorted.

"Alright. Suit yourself then." Phoebe concluded.

Like this, the two women stood apart from one another. Jason's eyes flickered between them, many strange thoughts swirling in his head.

Mainly, Jason couldn't stop thinking about how strangely Phoebe was acting, and what a massive power boost the Sphinx had given her. It was very different from the boost granted to the other three people who had acquired the Sphinx's power in the past.

Still, Jason kept his thoughts to himself. It was true that Phoebe had completely whooped Daisy's ass the last time they sparred. Even if Daisy got a MindCore upgrade, without using her powers, he didn't see a path to victory for her. Maybe what he saw as 'arrogance' on Phoebe's behalf was simply well-deserved confidence?

Daisy's expression grew solemn. Now that it came down to it, she was a little scared of pushing her MindCore right to 100% strength. At 50% she'd acted way out of character and really hurt Jerome. What if she turned into a mindless animal and beat the crap out of her mom? Daisy would never forgive herself.

But Phoebe was so casual about the whole affair, and Daisy had lost so badly to her last time, plus they were using the silly noodle swords... it would probably be fine.

Daisy tapped into her MindCore. She increased its power draw to 100%. In that moment, her senses sharpened to their maximum value, and the world around her came into sharp focus.

For the first time, Daisy started to see colors she hadn't before. It was as if the world had become enriched with ten new colors she didn't even originally know existed. When Daisy looked at Phoebe, she realized her mother's body was cloaked in a faint reddish hue. The hue was barely noticeable at the edges of her body, but extremely obvious around her chest, and especially her head. The intensity of the color pulsated irregularly. Daisy had no idea what it meant.

When Daisy's eyes flickered over to the other people in the room, she saw a whole assortment of colors. Marco and Brian were both colored blue, Sasha was purple, Nadia was green, and her father had a rainbow hue to him. Jerome wasn't there anymore, and Farrah hadn't shown up either, but Daisy already had a lot to take in, so she didn't notice.

They weren't standard colors. Daisy equated them to the colors she knew, but they were so dramatically different that she felt like she had to call them by weird names. Not blue or red, but Bled. Not yellow or orange, but 'yornglow'. It didn't make sense. What the hell were these colors?

Nobody in the room had any idea what Daisy was seeing. Phoebe raised her sword in a casual defensive stance.

"Your move first, young lady."

Daisy blinked her eyes, as if coming out of a daze. This was no time to be worrying about funny colors. She had a fight to win!

"I'm ready for anything!" Daisy said, as she raised her sword to match her mother.

Jason made a chopping motion with his hand.

"Round one, start!"

Part 777: Predator and Prey

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

As soon as Jason chopped his hand down, Daisy attacked.

She didn't tap into her powers at all. She had already done so the first time she sparred with her mother, and the two of them had engaged in a few minor practice sessions over the last few weeks, but Phoebe spent most of her time catching up on the trends of the modern world, being taught by Nadia and Jason about how modern society functioned. She didn't have time to train with the teenagers; that would come later.

Thus, this first round was merely Daisy wanting to determine the full extent of her MindCore's effects on her physical body. She didn't use her powers, only her animalistic instincts and sharpened senses. She wanted to figure out what her new baseline was, and if she used her powers out the gate, it would undermine that information.

Like this, Daisy lunged at Phoebe!

She jumped forward and sent a quick wrist-sweep of her sword toward Phoebe's chest.

Phoebe unhurriedly stepped back, allowing the blade to miss her leather shirt by an inch or so, as she'd done in all their previous spars.

Daisy followed up with a sidestep, a thrust, a sweep, and another thrust, quickly moving to close the distance. Her MindCore rapidly started showing her all the possible movements Phoebe could make, so she instinctively knew she would be able to close off her mother's evasive movements so long as she-

"You're overthinking it." Phoebe said, as she started speeding up, moving her body faster to match Daisy's brisk pace. She sidestepped the first stab, used her sword to knock the sweep slightly off-course, and turned her body ninety degrees to avoid the second stab.

Phoebe made no moves to attack. She simply dodged and deflected Daisy's attacks with the greatest of ease.

"Shit." Daisy cursed, gritting her teeth.

She attacked again, and again, and again. Phoebe, ever the noble knight, opted not to fight back, only to defend her position. She spotted dozens of openings she could easily

strike at to shut down Daisy's offense, but this spar was not about Phoebe's prestige. It was about teaching Daisy to utilize her MindCore more effectively.

The more Daisy moved, the more she began to intuit all the wonderful new changes her MindCore had given her. What was interesting was that it seemed to bestow upon her a form of combat comprehension similar to what Nadia possessed. Daisy was able to observe her mother's movements and mimic them much more easily, her brain absorbing its moment-to-moment losses and recontextualizing them to teach Daisy lessons about the art of combat.

A minute ticked by. Sweat started to accumulate on Daisy's forehead, while Phoebe appeared as unruffled as ever.

"You're way too aggressive." Phoebe remarked casually, sidestepping another thrust. "You fight as if the goal is for you to die of exhaustion before I ever counter-attack. This is not an effective combat style, let alone when engaging someone stronger than you."

Daisy grunted. Her mother's words felt slightly mocking, but they were steeped in a wisdom that could clearly only be gained by someone trained by King Arthur himself! Clearly her mother had gone through all sorts of crazy battles against the demons to become so wise. Daisy had no idea that Phoebe was only an above-average swordswoman before Bahamut took her. Capable of besting a young and inexperienced Jason in the future, but far from the increasingly lofty heights her daughter was now imagining her to be standing atop.

Jason had no idea his daughter's view of her mother had become so distorted. It didn't even occur to him that his daughter only recalled childish memories of her mother from when she was six years old, having zero concept of Phoebe's actual future combat competence.

The one time Daisy had been involved in a battle, she hadn't been on the battlefield along with her mother, and had only fought to protect her comatose body after Phoebe had totally exhausted herself on the front-lines.

Daisy paused her frenetic movements. She swallowed a few heavy breaths, feeling her lungs start to burn.

A minute of fighting might not seem like much, but the truth was, clashing blows with another person was exhausting, even more so when every attack ended up cutting the empty air. It meant all the force she'd put into every attack was wasted, burned up for

zero gain. Most humans could only sustain a minute or two of frantic fighting before they were totally exhausted. Daisy was way above the curve, she probably had several more minutes of gas left in her tank before she ended up a sputtering mess on the floor, but her baseline physical body was nothing extraordinary.

Daisy did not possess superhuman strength or durability, not innately. However, her telekinesis was capable of uplifting her physical parameters drastically. By 'coating' herself in telekinetic energy, she could greatly enhance the power of her attacks, enhance her defenses to the point she could even shrug off bullets, and amplify her speed by manipulating her body with her mind.

Thus, after a moment of deliberation, Daisy nodded.

"Alright, Miss Berthold. I'm... I'm going to use my full power now."

"Please do." Phoebe said, as she now assumed a much more dominating posture, both hands wrapped around the hilt of her sword. She stood facing Daisy, her legs slightly apart, firmly planted on the ground.

Daisy regulated her breathing. She sent her telekinesis inside her body, sweeping away her exhaustion and forcibly extracting the built-up C02 in her lungs. The burning sensation faded after a few moments.

Daisy had no way of knowing this, but if a Psion were to see her, they would immediately define her actions as those of a Body Enhancer Psion. Daisy's methods were crude, unrefined, and the product of an amateur with no formal instruction. Compared to the raw power even lowly 3rd and 4th Level Psions wielded, her body enhancing wasn't much to speak of. But even so, the fact a mere mud-dwelling species could be capable of mimicking a fraction of the Psion's capabilities would certainly alarm the Founders.

The young woman might not be aware of these things, but her father certainly was. While Nadia used her PepScan to observe the changes in Daisy's body, Jason did the same with a quiet bit of Wordsmithing. He had observed Daisy many times, so he was not surprised by her primitive form of Body Enhancing. Rather, he was surprised by how much more *smoothly* she completed the process. It was as if she had instinctively mastered some elements of her power without even thinking about them.

So that's how it is. Jason pondered. *The MindCore isn't just giving her 'animal' instincts, it's also helping her assemble the knowledge she already has into better-organized information that she can call upon instinctively. She already has lots of*

practice with her abilities, but the flow of her psionic energy is something like 40% smoother than it was before the surgery. I didn't know the QuantumReflex had such a property, but this IS why we do field tests; to gather hard data.

The muscles inside Daisy's body tightened and grew denser, far beyond what their mundane physical limits should allow. If a young woman aged eighteen could bench-press several hundred pounds after a year or two of training, Daisy was easily five to ten times beyond that level. She was reaching a level beyond even professional bodybuilders and MMA fighters.

At the same time, Daisy's telekinesis coated her skin, forming something like an invisible dermal armor. This was actually not part of Body Enhancing, but instead a different Psionic discipline known as Primal Psionics. By expanding their available psionic energy pool as much as possible, Primal Psions would gain the power to use huge 'blobs' of it for all sorts of vicious and blunt purposes.

However, if Daisy were to instead use small, surgical amounts of psionic energy to deflect bullets at lightning fast speeds, preventing those bullets from ever getting within a few feet of her body, this would instead be an application of Precision Psionics.

Daisy was capable of such a feat... albeit to a limited degree. She simply found it wasn't reliable enough to be used in a real world situation. In order to become a master of Precision Psionics, one would absolutely need to become a Brain Enhancer Psion first, and those were few and far between.

After a short few moments, Daisy completely restored her body to its peak physical condition, and elevated herself even beyond that. She momentarily frowned, looking down at her abdomen with a confused expression.

"Is something wrong?" Phoebe asked, now looking at the girl before her with a higher degree of wariness than before.

"No. Not wrong. Just... different." Daisy said, before pausing to add, "I feel like I can 'sense' more than I did before. My body seems stronger than the last time I 'boosted' myself. Maybe it's because of my MindCore."

"It almost certainly is." Phoebe said with a nod. "Come. Let's fight a bit more seriously this time."

With that, their second round began. Daisy lunged again, her movements astoundingly faster than before.

Phoebe's pupils shrunk. She darted backward, her body weaving left and right as Daisy sent out fast, yet measured slashes toward her. Vertical and horizontal cuts sliced the air, still missing Phoebe, but with a much smaller margin of error than before.

Their melee sped up even beyond that. Phoebe started rapidly battering her sword against Daisy's. The spectators gasped. This was way different compared to the first time Daisy had fought Phoebe a few weeks earlier. Phoebe was moving fast, anticipating Daisy's strikes, but Daisy was anticipating her dodges and performing quick feints to throw her off. At the same time, Phoebe recognized the feints and threw in counter-feints.

Daisy and Phoebe's swords started colliding, banging against each other like the sound of trees being slammed against the ground. Vibrations rang in the air, causing the onlookers to grit their teeth. The interesting thing about Jason's Noodle Swords was that they caused no damage when striking a person's body, and couldn't even be used to poke out an eye. But against physical objects, they struck with the same force as real wooden swords would, albeit indestructible ones.

Thump, thump, crack! Slam!

Phoebe batted Daisy's sword downward and it hit the floor hard enough to make the ground vibrate. The spectators felt that vibration rumble through their butts, given they were sitting on the floor a ways outside the arena.

"God damn. How hard are they hitting?!" Marco gasped.

"Hard enough that if they were to slap you, you'd probably have your head go flying." Brian replied.

"Unbelievable." Sasha said. "Daisy couldn't last more than a few minutes against Phoebe just a few weeks ago, but thanks to her MindCore, she's finally on par with Phoebe! I can't wait to get one of my own!"

Unfortunately, Farrah wasn't present to witness the incredible fight, and Jerome had stormed out. The remaining three could only chat among themselves.

Nadia, meanwhile, was much more aware of the truth of the fight.

"Daisy's still losing, and it's not close." Nadia remarked to Jason with a low mutter. "Phoebe's merely feeling her out."

Jason nodded. "Phoebe sure became incredible after obtaining the Sphinx. I never saw this level of power coming."

His attention was firmly focused on the fight. He didn't even notice when Nadia gave him a strange look out of the corner of her eye. Nadia returned her gaze to the arena and sighed. She had already deduced there was something going on with Phoebe beyond what she had told Jason. Phoebe wasn't telling him the full truth of what had happened, and that worried Nadia.

Nadia wouldn't let the man she loved be taken by surprise. Even if Jason wasn't *her* Jason, she still had to watch out for his blind spots. Phoebe and Daisy were by far his biggest weaknesses.

* * *

Two minutes passed. For once, Phoebe was starting to sweat a little, but Daisy was definitely looking worse for wear. She had eased up a little and not fought as aggressively, but it turned out that even her empowered body, definitely stronger than pre-MindCore, was still below Phoebe's physical form.

Daisy's arms were starting to hurt. Each time her sword collided with Phoebe's, it was like it had crashed against an anvil. Sometimes Daisy's sword even felt like it was about to get wrenched from her grasp, so she had to grip it even more tightly.

The young woman's fingers silently begged her for mercy. They were starting to weaken from all the impacts.

"You're still holding back." Phoebe said, dodging three more slashes while parrying a fourth. "Unleash all your telekinesis. It's the only way you can win!"

Daisy wanted to nod, but she simply didn't have a spare second to do so. She kept maintaining her furious assault while tapping into her telekinesis again.

At once, Phoebe's movements began to noticeably slow. Daisy started pressing down on her mother with a wall of telekinetic powers, increasing the gravity around her by a factor of ten. Phoebe's body, 140 pounds, suddenly felt like 1400 pounds, nearly 2/3rds of a metric ton.

Phoebe was still strong enough to resist the force, but now when she took a step, her feet struck the ground as if she were an even fatter Bael, causing footprints to indent into the floor.

With this added layer of obstruction, Phoebe and Daisy's combat capabilities abruptly equalized. Daisy's attacks finally started connecting. She landed her first glancing slice on Phoebe's right shoulder. Phoebe, not one to be one-upped by a teenager, immediately struck toward Daisy and landed a light cut on her collarbone.

Daisy knocked Phoebe's sword aside. The increased gravity made Phoebe's reaction time to pick the sword back up just a smidge too slow, so Daisy managed to land a horizontal chop on Phoebe's neck, earning her first full point. Her sword struck flesh, causing no injuries, but it made Phoebe wince.

"Alright. I guess I have to stop playing around." Phoebe muttered.

Phoebe's eyes metaphorically flashed. Her speed increased as she finally went all-out, rushing at Daisy to attack with all her strength. She chopped downward while Daisy swept her sword upward to deflect the attack, but too late, she realized she'd made a huge mistake. Phoebe's entire body was being dragged down by Daisy's gravitic pressure, and that made her sword ten times heavier, bolstered even more by Phoebe's tremendous strength.

CLAAAANG!

Phoebe battered Daisy's sword out of her hands, and Phoebe's sword crashed against Daisy's chest, stopping when it struck flesh.

"Guh!" Daisy coughed. Even though the sword hadn't hurt her, having her own sword torn out of her hands had finally sucked all the strength from her fingers. Daisy fell to her hands and knees, coughing wildly. Her telekinesis quickly faded due to exhaustion, and the room went quiet.

"Uhh.. uhh..." Daisy wheezed, not able to catch her breath. She found herself hyperventilating from exhaustion, while Phoebe was only a bit less tired. Even Phoebe was exhausted from the frantic assault.

Jason quickly came over and healed both women, relieving Daisy of her crippling chest pain. She swallowed several breaths, then plunked down on her butt with her head hung forward. She closed her eyes, feeling the wave of exhaustion somewhat cleared by her father's magic, yet still present in her brain itself. Phoebe's final attack hadn't only mangled the nerves in Daisy's hands, it had also overwhelmed her psionic energy reserves.

Daisy felt woozy. She hadn't fought a battle this intense... ever! Not even a single time. At her uncle's request, she'd been dealing with ordinary humans in the same way a soldier might shoot an ant with a bazooka. It was extreme overkill.

But now? Sparring with her mother on equal grounds? Daisy was completely wiped out.

She had to sit for a while before she could even refocus her hazy senses, lift up her head, and look at her mother seated across from her. Phoebe seemed like she still had some fight left in her, but she was pretty tired too.

"If you'd gone all out like that from the start, I might have lost without a chance of victory." Phoebe said, wiping her sweaty neck with a towel.

Daisy closed her eyes. "There's no need to be nice. You were going easy on me the whole time."

"Not at the end, I wasn't." Phoebe said quietly.

Daisy was too tired to argue, so she let the matter drop. Phoebe looked at the young woman with a complicated gaze. She closed her eyes, allowing her psyche to dip into her nascent Mind Realm, still slowly forming, but far from complete.

There, she saw Lord Elrin, the Sphinx, sitting by a pool, one of his front paws hanging into the water, the other resting on the pool's edge. Elrin was a bipedal creature, but he laid on his stomach like a cat would, lazily tracing his paw in a circle inside the pool's water.

[Not a bad fight. You're starting to attain a novice mastery of my simplified Sphinx combat styles.] Elrin said nonchalantly. [Inheritor, you have found a worthy training partner. It is vital that you spar with someone of roughly equal skill level, such as Daisy. Mentor that young woman well, and together, the two of you shall grow unstoppable together.]

"She's way stronger than me." Phoebe said, feeling slightly discouraged. She sat down cross-legged next to Elrin and hung her head, her arms flopping in her lap. "This body you've granted me is quite strong, but I fear it is not worth speaking of compared to those of the Demon Dukes and Emperors. Aside from my physical strength, I have little to draw upon."

[Hahaha. How little you know.] Elrin mused. [At my peak, I could annihilate planets with a wave of my paw. I wouldn't, of course, due to Akasha's laws, but it was within the realm of possibility if I ever felt suicidal enough. That little fight with the child earlier was like a play put on by toddlers, in my eyes. If you truly think you've reached the peak of the mountain, then I'll have to dump water on your head now.]

Elrin shook his head and smiled, causing his majestic mane to rustle gently. [If one must ascend a million steps to reach the peak of power, then you have barely climbed the first two, perhaps three. You're a little stronger than most mortals. They might worship you as a god, but your control of the Sphinx's lineage is a pitiful embarrassment.]

The Sphinx tapped his chin with his dry paw. [Hmm. You still haven't merged with the Sphinx long enough. I think I'll leave you as you are now. Inheritor, if you wish to become stronger, instead of coming here to beg me for greater strength, try learning to use the strength I've already given you to its highest potential. So far, you've been tapping into the Sphinx's Instincts mindlessly, allowing those instincts to control your body in the same way as that child is allowing her primitive little MindCore to control her.]

He continued. [It is like watching two power-armored soldiers using their suit's internal AI's to fight one another. A novice allows their base instincts to control them. A true master learns the lessons those instincts are trying to teach and adopts them into their internal world models. Once you accomplish such a feat, you will be ready for my next blessing.]

Phoebe nodded slowly. The talk of AI didn't mean anything to her, but she could generally glean what Lord Elrin was saying based on contextual clues. She'd been doing that a lot lately.

"I wasn't trying to beg you for more power." Phoebe grumbled.

[No, no, you weren't.] Elrin acknowledged. [But I can sense in your soul that you are feeling resentful about your momentary loss against the girl. This is good! One should never be content with their current level of power. That always causes a slow slide into sloth and decay. Every loss should be a brutal reminder; a wake-up call that you are not invincible and there is always a sky above the sky. Take today's battle, replay it in your mind, and learn as many lessons as possible. Crush the girl the next time you fight, then mentor her until she defeats you. Repeat over and over, and before long you will be ready for my next gift.]

Phoebe exhaled, feeling the tension leave her body.

"Yes, Lord Elrin."

[Begone, then.] Elrin said, casually waving his paw in a 'get out' gesture. [Until next time.]

Phoebe's vision dimmed., She returned to the world of the living and made a grand display of yawning to hide the fact she'd been comatose again. Luckily, this time she'd only 'dozed off' for a few minutes, so nobody was any the wiser.

Jason chatted with Phoebe for a while. He asked Phoebe how she felt Daisy was progressing, and, spurred on by Elrin's words, Phoebe chose to praise Daisy's growth while acknowledging her own faults.

Phoebe enjoyed speaking honestly. She hated telling lies, and even just hiding Elrin's existence made her deeply uncomfortable. What she did not know was that Nadia was always keeping an eye on her from a distance. She had already started to notice certain patterns and was carefully fitting pieces of a puzzle together.

Still, Nadia said nothing. She didn't rat Phoebe out, nor did she confront her. Phoebe was oblivious to Nadia's quiet machinations.

Eventually, Phoebe and the others headed out. Daisy was left alone with her father and Nadia.

"How are you feeling?" Jason asked.

"Physically? Fine." Daisy said. "But psychologically..."

"You did a great job." Jason said, going to great lengths to praise his little girl. "This MindCore will be a game changer for you. Nadia and I will see if we can get a new training regimen set up for you as soon as possible. We'll make sure to challenge you so you can grow stronger as quickly as possible."

Daisy smiled at her father, but then her joy faded. She looked at the ground guiltily.

"Dad... what about Jerome? He was so mad earlier, I feel kinda bad."

"Don't you worry about Jerome." Jason said, making an 'x' shape with his palms. "Your old man's got it under control. I'm going to have a talk with him."

"Jason, before you go," Nadia said, "I just wanted to point out that Jerome's acting a little different from usual. He's typically quite respectable when he fights, and he always

appreciates a good challenge. The way he blew up at Daisy isn't how he usually would act."

"I noticed that too." Jason acknowledged. "He acts like a rough street urchin badass, but he's always so gentle with Farrah. He has a soft side, but he puts up an emotional wall and doesn't let others in."

"Except Farrah." Daisy pointed out.

"Yeah. He tells her everything." Jason said, his voice trailing off as if he'd realized something.

The Wordsmith fell into deep thought. He stroked his chin and muttered something the other two couldn't quite catch.

"Yeah. I'll go find and talk to him now." Jason said. "Daisy, you should go get some sleep. My Wordsmithing heals the body, but it's not too useful when it comes to your mind."

"Okay, dad." Daisy said, smiling and nodding obediently. "Hope things go well with Jerome..."

"So do I." Jason said.

He uttered a Word of Power, then vanished from the spot.

Part 778: Man-to-Man Talk

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

It was not difficult for Jason to find Jerome. It hadn't even been half an hour since he left the training facility, and he was a huge guy. He stood out in the barren city of Aevum, not that he could have hidden from the Wordsmith even if he wanted. Jerome had gone to a park filled with trees half a kilometer to the east. He had grabbed onto a tree branch and started doing pullups, but Jason had no idea how many he'd done by the time he arrived.

Jason teleported a few hundred feet away, then approached on foot.

"Jerome." Jason called out.

"The fuck you want?" Jerome snapped, glaring at him. "Finally coming over to ring me out, huh? Couldn't stand I called your precious baby daughter a bitch?"

"Well, yes." Jason said calmly. He stopped a little ways away, watching as Jerome continued to pull his body up and down using only his arms. "That was uncalled for. It's also not like the Jerome I know."

"Yeah? And how fuckin' well do you know me anyway?" Jerome growled, looking away. "You don't. Not one bit."

A moment of silence followed. Jason leaned back against a different tree while still facing the young man.

"You're right. It's only been a month or two since we met... depending on how you judge differing scales of time. But I do know that, despite your huge body and overwhelming strength, you're usually a well-spoken young man with a kind heart. This is the first time I've seen you snap over something relatively minor."

"Minor?!" Jerome shouted, finally releasing his grip on the tree branch. He landed on his feet and stood up, striding toward Jason, only stopping a short distance away. "Daisy slapped my ears so hard I thought she burst my god-damned eardrums! That shit hurt! You got any idea how bad that hurt?!"

"I can... imagine." Jason said, mentally recalling a few thousand similar moments of insane pain he'd experienced in his life. "Is that it, then? You've turned into a big, whining baby because my daughter hurt you during sparring?"

"I was taking it so easy on her, helping her test out her new mind-bullshit, and she crossed a line." Jerome said, pointing an accusatory finger at Jason. "You always take her side because she's your daughter. That's the truth! Spoiled little Trueborn girl with a godly-powerful Trueborn daddy time-traveling from the future! Some people get all the luck and can act however they want! But for the rest of us, we've got a whole other set of rules we gotta play by! I guarantee if I did to her what she did to me, you'd be singin' a different tune!"

Jason was quiet for a moment. "That's really what you think, huh? There's so much wrong with what you just said, I'm not sure know where to start."

He thought to himself before continuing. "You said Daisy is 'spoiled.' I assume that means you've had a hard life, then? Harder than hers?"

"Way harder!" Jerome said, throwing up his hands as if it was the most obvious thing in the world. "I grew up on the streets. I got the shit kicked out of me five times a day. Lucky I made it out of childhood alive! You think I was this strong my whole life? HELL no! I was stuck in the foster system, passed around like poisoned meat, hearing all sorts of nasty slurs and shit my entire childhood. They treated me like an animal!"

Jason stayed quiet, simply listening as Jerome continued. "I only got my powers a year ago. Before that, I learned to fight not cuz' I wanted to, but cuz' I HAD to! If I didn't know how to fight, I'd be dead now. The fuck's a privileged little white girl with Uncle Bigbucks know about that kind of life, huh? Must be nice, having a powerful Russian guy adopt her, put her in all the nicest clothes, feed her the best food. And her dad's a fuckin' GOD among men!"

Jason closed his eyes and massaged his forehead with two fingers.

"Daisy... hasn't talked to you or the others from the Illuminati about her childhood, has she?"

"Sure she has." Jerome retorted. "How d'you think I knew about her uncle?"

"Right. That's the surface level." Jason said quietly. He looked at Jerome with deep meaning. "You're assuming a lot of stuff about Daisy. Those assumptions are dangerous. They're also wrong. Very, very wrong."

The Wordsmith slowly licked his lips, searching for the right words. "Let's get one thing out of the way, Jerome. You've had a terrible life. Based purely on what you told me,

I wouldn't wish it on anyone else. I don't know you as a person all that well, and you don't know Daisy, *certainly* not me, that well either."

Jason continued. "I have big plans for you, Jerome. But if you're going to keep on lashing out like this without getting the full story, making assumptions, getting all self-righteous, then maybe you're not a good fit for Aevum."

Jerome rolled his eyes. "And there it is. The black man gets yappy and you shut him down."

"It's not about that." Jason said. "If my daughter isn't willing to talk about certain things, then it's not my place to speak in her stead. But in this one instance, I'm going to make an exception. Jerome, you already know I come from the far future. I'm sure you've heards bits and pieces of it here and there. But what you might not understand is the totality of evil that happened in that future."

Jason pulled away from the tree and stood up straight. At 5'10", he was a full head shorter than Jerome. He appeared physically weaker than the young man, certainly not as dominating, but Jason had a confidence about himself that could only come from a self-actualized man who knew exactly who he was and of what he was capable. He didn't lose out to his far larger and more physically imposing verbal opponent at all.

"The future I awoke in was 100,000 years from now." Jason began. "It started with me exiting my cryopod, only to be chased around by a terrifying monster named Gressil. This creature was ravenous, and bloodthirsty, but also highly intelligent. I only learned later that he was a demon, like so many others, and the demons had completely enslaved all of humanity."

Jason proceeded to regale Jerome with a brief overview of his life's story. The young man listened, his expression unchanging, his arms crossed. The tale was fantastical, but he'd heard parts of it here and there, so he wasn't surprised by the details being filled out.

"That was when I met the woman who would become my wife for the first time." Jason continued. "Her name was Phoebe. Phoebe Berthold."

Jerome blinked. "What? Phoebe? As in... the white-haired lady you brought here a few weeks ago? The same one? She's your wife?"

"In the future, she was my wife." Jason said quietly. "The Phoebe you know is her younger self. She does not know me in that way. We are, effectively, strangers. Her older,

future self, was also Daisy's mother."

Jerome blinked again. This was new information for him. "Wait, wait, wait. So you're telling me you time-traveled back to the past, but you didn't bring your woman along? Only your *daughter*??"

"My story is far from complete." Jason explained. "After I met Phoebe, a lot of things happened. I won't bore you with all the details, but there were huge battles, and several years of relative peace. I had to fight the Black Witch, the first girl I loved, and I ultimately killed her due to her monstrous acts."

"After that, Phoebe gave birth to our daughter, Daisy. The era of peace followed, with humanity working to improve its circumstances, while my clone, Hope, went on to work alongside the military."

"...Then came Emperor Ose. She was one of humanity's greatest enemies."

"...A huge battle followed. Betrayals, violence you can't imagine. We lost a lot of good soldiers."

"...That was when the turning point came. Daisy revealed her powers for the first time. She was only six years old. She summoned monsters capable of leveling cities, Titans, and fought back against Ose."

"...The battle seemed to finally be turning around. That was when Beelzebub burst out of the ground and detonated his body in the skies above Tarus II. That was when Daisy died."

Jerome was taken aback. He lowered his arms from their crossed position. "She... died?"

"I thought she did." Jason said quietly. "In fact, she ended up time traveling. I don't know how or why she did, but she did. She returned to the past, to this era, but twelve years ago, a little girl age six."

Jerome started to put some puzzle pieces together. "So you didn't bring her back with you? She came here on her own, and you came later?"

Jason didn't answer Jerome's question immediately. "When Daisy arrived... even I don't know the details. She hasn't opened up to me about what happened yet. But what I *do* know is, she teleported around and was caught by the Russians. By the Russian *government*. They kidnapped her, bound her, and put her in some sort of... facility...

where they began torturing and experimenting on her, trying to control her powers for themselves, weaponize her, and create other superhumans like her."

Jerome's face warped in horror. "When she was only six years old?! Man, what the *fuck*..."

"I don't know exactly how long Daisy was in those facilities, and I don't know what she went through." Jason said quietly. "I know they injected her with needles, forced her to kill animals, beat her, did all sorts of other things that churn my stomach. I know she was in their custody for around two years. They made her kill other things, especially orphaned kids. They broke her mind and nearly turned her into a feral beast."

"Later," Jason continued, "she was picked up by 'Vasily Sokolov', the guy she calls 'Uncle Vasily'. I know nothing about the man, but I fear his 'rescuing' her may have had ulterior motives behind it. I worry he is not as good a man as Daisy believes. When I have time, I'll be looking into him, among many others."

Jason paused to allow Jerome to parse what he'd said. "While Daisy was here, in this era, suffering without a mother or a father to protect her, I was enduring a hellish future, watching as my friends and family died. In the end, even my wife ended up dead. I held Phoebe's corpse in my arms right before I made the decision to travel back in time to change the past."

Jason looked at Jerome knowingly. "I'm not telling you all this to discount the awful life you've lived, Jerome. I don't doubt it was hellish and awful. But knowing everything I've told you, do you really think Daisy is some spoiled white girl living a life of privilege? Is that the hill you want to die on?"

Any last bit of Jerome's anger had long ago fizzled out. He lowered his head, feeling ashamed of himself. "No, mister Hiro."

"Good. That's good." Jason said. "Come, sit with me. Let's have a man to man talk."

"Um. Aren't we doing that now?" Jerome asked, puzzled.

"That was just the prelude." Jason said, gesturing to the shady spot under the tree.

Jerome obliged. He sat beneath the tree, and Jason plunked down beside him.

Both men were quiet for a while before Jason broke the silence.

"I don't know you well, Jerome, but I know you well enough to know you're not acting like yourself. Even if you *did* think Daisy was some spoiled little rich girl, you would have

held back and not spat such vile words at her. So what's eating you?"

Jerome chewed his lower lip. He seemed uncomfortable. "I... I don't know."

"Sure you do. Something's bothering you." Jason said. "You put on the act of a tough guy, but I've met a lot of 'tough guys' in my time. Compared to them, you're a softie at heart. Something must be chewing your ear to get you so worked up."

Jerome was quiet again, for a time. Then he sighed.

"It's... it's uh, it's my girlfriend. Farrah. She ain't talked to me for two days. She's avoiding me. I think I fucked up, but I don't know what I did wrong. I must've pissed her off, but I don't know how."

"Farrah?" Jason blinked. "She's not talking to you?"

"Nah, man. It was so abrupt. One day, we was fine. The next, we wasn't." Jerome muttered. He hung his head, feeling lower than dirt. "I just... I love her so much. I don't know what I'd do without her. Knowing I pissed her off, it's making me doubt who I am... makin' me doubt what I'm doin' with my life."

Jason gave Jerome a strange look, but quickly glanced away.

"How did the two of you meet?" Jason asked.

Jerome thought for a moment. "Well, it was a little over three years ago. Before I got my powers, or she got hers. Farrah's not like me. She has a family and shit. But they were... um... abusive. They were trying to arrange a marriage for her with some rich American guy. So she ran away when she was visiting the USA. Got lost on the streets, surrounded by some real bad guys. She was a pretty Persian girl, all alone."

Jerome shrugged. "I couldn't let a nice girl like her get... you know... so I jumped in. Managed to fight 'em off, but got the shit beat out of me. She helped me back to my place... wasn't much of a 'place' worth talkin' about. Just some run-down abandoned room in Detroit."

Jerome mumbled a lot when he talked about Farrah, but luckily, Jason was able to make out all the words.

"So anyway, I told her she should go back to her family. Streets weren't safe for a nice girl like her... plus she was way outta my league. I dunno. I guess she just liked me or something. She wanted to stay."

Jerome heaved a sigh. "Apparently her family were like conservative types or whatever, had been trainin' her to be a 'proper wife' her whole life. She knew how to cook and stuff. Helped spruce up my place a bit. Made it more livable. Days turned into weeks, then months. She stuck with me even through the cold winters."

Jerome smiled slightly. "It was the first time in my life I didn't feel like a worthless piece of shit. I even felt happy. I didn't have to put on an act around her. Man, I ain't badass. I'm hardened. There's a difference. I had a shit life and had to grow up quick so the bigger kids wouldn't kill me. But I never wanted any of that."

"After a year of livin' with Farrah in the slums, I wanted to get out and do better, get a job, be a proper adult 'n shit, but we were both only 16. Only jobs we could find were shitty ones working under skeevy guys. She didn't have her papers, and didn't want her family to find her. I didn't have any papers at all. So we had to work under the table. Make a living illegally."

Jason nodded. It was, in the broadest sense, similar to what he'd surmised. He'd gotten a lot of the details wrong, but that was how these things went.

"Anyway, stuff happened, we managed to work our way up outta the gutter, and then we suddenly got our powers. That was when we was 17." Jerome said, doing the mental math. "Farrah woke up one morning with a new face. Scared the shit outta me. Scared the shit outta her, too. She realized she could change the way her face looked, and I realized I was feelin' stronger than the day before. Accidentally tore the knob off our apartment door."

"Then the Illuminati came. Picked us up a month after we got our powers. Took us to their facility. Me and Farrah were real scared at first, thinkin' they was gonna separate us, or ship her back home, but it all ended up workin' out okay in the end."

Jerome tossed his hands in the air. "But now she ain't talkin' to me. I don't know what I did wrong. It's got me all fucked up, man. She means the world to me."

Jason licked his lips. He smiled and nodded. "Well, good news, Jerome. I don't think she's mad at you. Not at all. This is... probably my fault."

"Your fault?" Jerome asked, quickly turning his head to direct a suspicious look Jason's way. "The fuck's that mean?"

Jerome immediately seemed to think Jason had made a move on Farrah, but it didn't take long for him to realize that made no sense. Jason had no interest in her when his future wife was right there. Jerome cooled down and waited for Jason's explanation.

"I was talking to Farrah about her power." Jason explained. "I thought her shapeshifting seemed fairly weak, or like she wasn't going far enough with it. So... I made a suggestion, and it seemed to work out for her. I just didn't realize she would decide not to tell you, and hide from you. We talked two days ago, so the events line up..."

"What kind of breakthrough did she make?" Jerome pressed. "You're being awfully vague."

"It's up to her to tell you. Give her some space for a while." Jason said. "You two are always attached at the hip, but that's not good for you or her. You can't develop into individual people if you're always reliant on one another."

"I mean... I *guess* you have a point." Jerome muttered. "You're sure she ain't mad at me?"

"I suppose she could be, but it's pretty unlikely." Jason said. "She probably just wants some privacy while she messes around with her new powers. Give her some space. Work on yourself... and that anger problem."

Jason's smile disappeared.

"I'm a pretty understanding guy, Jerome. I don't let my anger get the better of me unless I'm pushed to my breaking point. Like I said before, I have big plans for you. But if you *ever* treat my daughter like that again, I'll beat the shit out of you and throw you out of Aevum. You had the excuse of ignorance before, because you didn't know her story and you made some bad assumptions. But even if you were *right* and she *was* just some privileged little girl, it was a bitch move of you to snap at her like that."

Jerome frowned. "If I was right, then that would mean she'd still broken the rules!"

"And who broke the rules first?" Jason countered. "The rules said no blows to the head, but you kept slapping her around and throwing her to the mat. You think that didn't hurt? She's a tenth your size soaking wet. You can't say she broke the rules when you broke them first."

"You didn't call time-out or anything." Jerome scoffed. "You were complicit."

"I was, because I could tell you were holding back." Jason said. "If Daisy had complained, I would have stopped the match. But my daughter is made of tough stuff. Even getting thrashed by you, she didn't complain. You, on the other hand, suffered one hard hit and threw a fit. Like a *child*. You stormed out of the room like a 6-year-old would. That's unacceptable."

It looked like Jerome wanted to say something, but he thought better of it and just looked away.

"I guess you're right. Sorry. I don't... know... what I was thinking." Jerome mumbled. "I always have to hold back. It ain't fair when a guy fights a girl. If I win, I'm a woman-beater. If I lose, I'm a bitch who lost to a woman. If I hit too hard, I'm being abusive. I'm used to others seeing me as the 'bad guy' when it's me versus any girl."

Jason nodded. "I get that. Though, in my experience, women might be the 'weaker' sex among ordinary humans, but I've met too many absolutely terrifying demonesses to think they fall into that category."

"Like Ose?" Jerome asked.

"Yeah. Like Ose." Jason said.

Another silence fell between the two men.

"When you said you had 'big plans' for me, what did you mean?" Jerome inquired. "Ain't we just training to fight the demons?"

"It's not as simple as that." Jason said. "I'm developing a strategy as we go along. I'm thinking of ways to improve the powers of all of you and develop equipment customized to boost your strengths. And for you, specifically, I believe you will become the leader of the Lowborn."

Jason frowned. "But *not* if you continue to fire off that mouth of yours. You lost a lot of respect from your peers today. Leaders have to be calm, stable, and in control. Irrational idiots quickly lose the hearts of their soldiers and end up abandoned. If you can't act like a man moving forward, I'll find another leader for the Lowborn."

Jerome closed his eyes.

"I'm sorry about what I said earlier, Mister Hiro. I'll apologize to Daisy and the others later."

"That would be smart." Jason said. "Now, if you'll excuse me, I need to be on my way. I still have other tests to run on Daisy's new MindCore."

Jason stood up, then looked back down at Jerome. "Don't tell Daisy or Phoebe anything I've told you. This stays between us."

"Yes, sir." Jerome said with a nod.

Jason found it slightly amusing a guy three times his size was addressing him so respectfully, but it wasn't unexpected or beyond the pale. He patted Jerome's shoulder, then uttered a Word of Power before vanishing.

Jerome was left alone with his thoughts. He had a lot on his mind.

Part 779: Adrenaline

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Daisy, exhausted from her sparring matches against Jerome and Phoebe, had gone to bed early for the day. The other teenagers were hotly discussing what they'd seen, with all of them excited by how drastically Daisy's improvements had ended up being.

By this point, the benefits of Jason's MindCores were fully proven. The side effects had been pretty bad before, which made the teens wary, but Daisy's MindCore had zero side effects at all! That meant Jason had finally ironed out the majority of kinks, and future MindCores would have few if any issues worth mentioning. The teens were looking forward to their powerups.

Jason teleported back into the sparring ring. He looked around and saw Phoebe chatting with Nadia on one side of the ring, while Bryan, Marco, and Sasha were discussing the previous sparring matches on the other side.

The Wordsmith's eyes fell on Phoebe for a moment. He enjoyed looking at her. He enjoyed drinking in her beauty. But he never allowed himself to look long, especially when, despite having her back turned to him, Phoebe turned around and smiled at him. Somehow, she had immediately sensed his arrival.

He smiled back, then turned to look at the teenagers.

"So, kids." Jason said, wandering over to them. "I've decided I'm going to give Sasha the next MindCore, then Brian, then Marco. Are you all okay with that?"

All three of them nodded.

"Sasha has the most useful power. It's the most brain-focused." Brian said.

"I'd prefer to go last anyway." Marco said, lowering his eyes. "I still don't think my power has much use."

Jason sighed. Marco's self esteem was, by far, the lowest of all the people in Aevum. He constantly doubted himself. He was rather spineless, in many ways. It wasn't a good quality for someone who might have to fight demons in the future. Maybe just keeping him in a backline support role would be for the best. Jason could easily get months, even

years of work done in mere Aevum-minutes, provided he could handle the sustained isolation from all other forms of life.

If that was all Marco was ever good for, it would be a tremendous boon for humanity, but Jason felt bad, knowing he'd be reducing a potential powerhouse to a mere finger-snapping assistant. *Surely* Marco's powers had way more utility than even Jason had thought of yet.

"Sasha's Alchemy has countless support and combat uses." Jason said. "The fact her powers are mentally-focused definitely means she needs a MindCore the most. But don't discount yourselves. Brian, I knew an incredible fire manipulator in the future I came from. His name was Beelzebub, and I fear if he hadn't joined humanity's side, he could have stayed one of our most dangerous enemies."

Jason turned his head toward Marco. "And Marco, I've never known *anyone* with an ability like yours. It's utterly unique. You've got to grow a spine and start thinking better of yourself. Hopefully this new MindCore helps you out with that..."

Marco shrugged. He didn't seem too enthusiastic about the whole thing, though he was naturally interested in becoming smarter. Even if he didn't think highly of himself, he did at least think a MindCore would put him above the level of most ordinary humans. Getting a good job in the future wouldn't be too hard with such a boon.

The fact he was still thinking of mundane things like 'jobs' when the fate of humanity was at stake went even further to show just how out-of-the-game his head was.

After setting up appointments for each of the teenagers' MindCore installations, Jason turned and strolled over to Nadia and Phoebe, who had fallen silent after Jason arrived. Whatever they'd been discussing was likely idle small talk. They were much more interested in Jason, whenever he was present.

"Am I interrupting anything?" Jason asked.

"Not really." Nadia said. "Well, actually, Jason, I did notice something when Phoebe and Daisy were sparring. I'm sure you noticed it too."

"Her enhanced reflexes?" Jason asked.

"Yes, exactly." Nadia replied. "During the match, I was struck with the thought that Daisy and Phoebe were moving in an eerily similar manner."

Like mother, like daughter. Jason thought. He didn't voice those words.

"To me," Nadia continued, "I felt as though I were looking at two iterations of the QuantumReflex MindCore. It was as if Daisy had one, and so did Phoebe. Except, I thought that Phoebe's was much, much more advanced."

Jason blinked. He looked at Phoebe, her face blank and uncomprehending.

Is Nadia saying she thinks Phoebe spontaneously grew a MindCore? That certainly seems outside the realm of possibility. I guess stranger things have happened though. Maybe that Sphinx powerup seriously juiced her more than I ever anticipated!

"Phoebe, mind if we poke around in your head, then?" Jason asked. "You can say no, if you want. I intended to give you a MindCore in the future, so if you're at all interested, it won't hurt to do a check-up now."

Phoebe fidgeted a little, seeming surprisingly more nervous than usual. "Well... okay then. I suppose it couldn't hurt."

With that, Jason, Nadia, and Phoebe vanished, leaving the teenagers behind.

After a few moments, Brian coughed. "The Archseer really is building quite the harem, isn't be?"

"Harem?" Marco asked. "What makes you say that?"

Sasha and Brian both gave him pitying looks.

"Marco, it's pretty obvious Nadia's fallen head-over-heels for him." Sasha said. "Phoebe can't keep her eyes off him, and don't forget when Heaven's Daughter was here."

Marco was completely oblivious. "You're saying all three of them... *like* him?"

"Uh. Yes. Something like that." Brian said, laughing quietly to himself. He shook his head at Marco's unknowing expression. "Someday, you'll meet a nice grl, and it'll make sense then."

"I'll take your word on it." Marco said with a shrug.

* * *

Jason and the two women appeared inside the medical center. Phoebe laid back in the examination chair, and Jason held both his palms an inch away from both sides of her head, while Nadia donned her PepScan and watched from the side.

Jason uttered a Word of Power, then his soul exited his body and dove into Phoebe's glabella.

As soon as Jason entered her mind, his eyes were blinded by a brilliant light.

[Ahhh!] Jason cried out. [W-what the hell! What's this light? What is this?!]

If his soul had tear ducts, his eyes would definitely be watering. It was like looking directly at the sun, except the 'sun' was shining its brilliant light from all directions, simultaneously. It resembled Heaven's Light, but was far brighter. It even made Raphael's False Cosmic Realm feel somewhat dull.

Jason sensed, but couldn't really see, Phoebe's soul-form materialize beside him.

[Is something wrong?] Phoebe asked, perplexed.

[Are you seriously asking me that?] Jason retorted, trying fruitlessly to cover his eyes with his hands. He failed, due to his hands being mostly transparent. [What is this crazy blinding light?]

Phoebe looked around. She shrugged. [I don't know. It doesn't seem all that bright to me...]

Jason's jaw dropped. He couldn't believe how blasé her reaction was regarding what her inner self looked like. Had she already grown fully accustomed to her strange Mind Realm, to the point its existence was utterly banal? Or maybe it truly didn't seem bright at all to her, and it only did to Jason because he was a foreign soul?

Jason did not know the answer.

After poking around a while, Jason convinced Phoebe to 'mess around' with her Mind Realm a little. Eventually, the light levels dropped, and a planet came into view.

Jason was shellshocked. As the light dimmed and he became more and more capable of gazing upon Phoebe's Mind Realm, he realized Nadia was completely correct. Somehow, Phoebe had developed a massive Mind Realm bigger than any of Jason's MindCores, more power efficient than any of his newest versions, and so rich in life energy he was left reeling.

The world that stretched out before him appeared somewhat barren at first glance. It was a planet similar to Earth, but with a purple sky that tinted the world below in a similar hue. There were strange creatures roaming the planet Jason didn't recognize at all. One thing was for sure though; they were completely alien life forms. There were bipedal Sentients of many different types living in cities made up of different

technological eras, wildlife living in vast forests the size of the Amazon, deserts and tundras, plains, farmlands...

Phoebe's Mind Realm appeared to be made up of multiple alien civilizations, all somehow coexisting on the same world. By now, Jason was feeling extremely doubtful, even suspicious.

Never, never, not *ever* had any of the Sphinxes he knew mentioned anything about growing an alien Mind Realm in their heads. At this point, Phoebe's Sphinx power-up was so exaggerated he was beginning to doubt if he'd planted the Sphinx in her, or the seed of some long-dead ancient galactic civilization.

[What do you make of all this?] Jason asked, directing his question to Phoebe's presence floating beside him as he flew across her Mind World.

[It is incredible...] Phoebe said quietly. [All of this... is inside me? All these strange people and animals?]

Jason looked at Phoebe, turned away, then quickly looked back with an expression of shock. [You didn't know about your inner Mind Realm?!]

[I wasn't able to look inside myself until you showed me it was possible.] Phoebe explained. [What does this mean? Is this what your MindCore looks like?]

Jason scoffed. [If my MindCores were 5% as majestic as your Mind Realm, humanity would become unstoppable. Whatever the hell the Sphinx power did to your body, it amplified your brain ten times more. No wonder you were dogging Daisy the whole fight.]

[Dogging?] Phoebe asked, perplexed. [Do you mean... licking her with my tongue? I did no such thing...]

[No! I meant, uh, kicking her butt during the fight.] Jason hastily explained.

Phoebe's soulform squinted at him. [I did not kick her posterior...]

[No it's- never mind.] Jason sighed, giving up instead of digging a deeper hole with his words. [I'm just saying, this Mind Realm is extremely impressive. I don't even know how to start evaluating it.]

Jason retracted his soul from Phoebe's Mind Realm. He and her awoke at the same time, with Jason feeling somewhat fatigued. It seemed that merely spending time in direct proximity to her powerful soul was a draining experience for him. By now, he

understood that this Phoebe had diverged so far from the Phoebe he knew that he had to completely reassess her capabilities.

Her personality seemed mostly the same, but the way she addressed him, the way she looked at him, the way she conducted herself, all of it presented an image of a twin sister who looked the same externally, but did not think the same way internally.

And that made sense. This Phoebe had awoken in the modern era, a time where humans were still somewhat the rulers of Earth. Waking up in a distant future where humanity had become slaves and chattel would prove to be a mind-altering moment, perhaps even traumatic in many ways. Jason needed only look at Catherine as an example of what differing circumstances could lead to.

"Well." Jason said, as he turned to Nadia and rubbed his tired eyes. "We... won't be able to give Phoebe a MindCore. But it doesn't seem she needs one either."

He explained to Nadia what he'd seen. Nadia stayed quiet, merely listening and nodding as Jason talked. Every so often, she would direct a sly glance at Phoebe, seemingly an idle movement of her eyes, yet one that also seemed to speak of secret insights she was making in her mind, yet not expressing verbally.

"An entire planet within her mind? It almost sounds similar to a single simulated instance inside a RealitySim. Except it isn't a simulation, it appears to be a living world with real or otherwise lifelike entities living within. Not to mention Phoebe demonstrated mental abilities in the same vein as Daisy's QuantumReflex. I'm guessing the two of them are based on similar principles, but Phoebe's is far more advanced. Jason, you could drastically improve the future MindCores you develop if you were to study the design of Phoebe's Mind Realm first."

Jason slowly nodded. "Your words make sense, but... I don't know. Being in close proximity to Phoebe's Mind Realm was an exhausting experience. I'm hesitant to go poking around in there again."

Nadia bobbed her head, ever so slightly. It was almost as if she was thinking, *ah yes, exactly the intended effect*. Jason was too tired to notice.

After finishing up, Jason turned back to Phoebe. "Hey, while you're here, I had something I wanted to run by you."

Phoebe got out of the chair and stretched, popping her back. "What is it?"

"I was thinking we needed more recreational activities in Aevum." Jason explained. "You mind checking out the first one I built? Nadia, you can come along too."

Nadia pursed her lips. "No, that's fine. I have a project I need to work on. You and Miss Berthold go ahead. Fill me in later."

Without further ado, she strolled out of the medical center. Jason was slightly perplexed. Nadia usually chose to join him on activities like this. Perhaps she was just tired from all the excitement.

"I'll teleport us there." Jason said to Phoebe with a smile.

A moment later, Jason uttered a Word of Power. He and Phoebe vanished, reappearing just outside Argent City, within the Proving Grounds. Here, a massive electrified fence had been erected, forming a large oval-shaped arena. There were bleachers capable of seating 1000 people, not gigantic compared to stadiums on Earth, but certainly far outstripping Aevum's current population.

"This is a racing track." Jason said, smiling cheerfully at Phoebe. "This is where people driving in cars can race one another."

Phoebe frowned. She looked around the field, slightly uncomprehending.

"Cars..." Phoebe said, before she remembered something she'd read recently. "One of those 'motorized vehicles', like Planes, but on the ground?"

"Yes!" Jason said. "I have a feeling you'll really enjoy this activity in your free time. Let me show you how it works."

Jason waved his hand. Immediately, a bright red Ferrari materialized before him and Phoebe on the race track. Phoebe examined it with mild interest, but she knew very little about automobiles, so she had about the same interest in it as she would if Jason were showing her a collection of butterflies taped inside a book.

Jason popped open the passenger door and gestured inside. "I will be sitting over there and driving. You'll be sitting here, in the passenger seat. This vehicle drives extremely fast. It's a real adrenaline-pumper, and it might be scary at first. It makes a really loud noise, but don't be frightened!"

He remembered the first time he'd introduced his wife to a car, and he'd scared her so badly she had started sobbing uncontrollably. Jason learned from his mistakes and spent a few minutes acclimating her to the concept, not wanting her to cry like she had before.

"Fascinating." Phoebe said, still only mildly interested. "You said this car moves extremely quickly?"

"Oh yes, this will get your blood pumping." Jason assured her. "You want to take it for a spin?"

Phoebe looked at him quizzically. "A spin? Driving in circles?"

"It's, ah, an expression..." Jason said, realizing he'd once again used a common turn of phrase she wasn't familiar with. "Sorry..."

"No worries. I'll spin with you." Phoebe said, smiling sweetly. "So I just... climb into this seat here?"

Jason nodded, then helped her into the Ferrari, also showing her how to buckle her seatbelt. After he closed the passenger door, he jogged around to the other side, climbed inside the driver's seat, and shut the door.

Jason grinned like a kid opening a present on Christmas Day. He was so excited, getting to relive a core memory with the new Phoebe. Of course, the first time he drove her around had been extremely scary for her, but it had also morphed into her love of racing.

Unfortunately, Phoebe had always been so busy acting as the brains of humanity's military that she never had time to devote to her driving. Jason was sure she would have gone racing every day if she'd had more free time. That thought left him feeling a little melancholic, which made his expression dim. Now his wife would never have that opportunity again...

"Is something the matter?" Phoebe asked, seeing the smile slip from his face.

"Oh, no. It's nothing." Jason said, quickly reassuring her while returning to his previous expression. "Let's have some fun!"

Jason turned on the engine and let it sit for a few moments, allowing Phoebe to acclimate to it before gently revving the engine a little more. He looked at the face of his wife-not-wife, but he was surprised to see she seemed as disinterested as before. It seemed as if she were merely politely going through the motions to make him happy, rather than showing any real interest the activity herself.

That was when a thought struck him.

Was it possible, in his caution to acclimate her to the car, that he'd been *too* careful? What if the trauma of future-Phoebe's first encounter with a car had left her adrenaline racing? What if it was the element of fear that had led to her excitement? By carefully explaining every little thing, was it possible that he had inadvertently stunted past-Phoebe's interest in driving?!

That wouldn't do. Jason knew that Phoebe was a speed freak, an adrenaline junkie. He had to make sure today left a lasting impact on her.

Thus, acting on instinct, he suddenly jammed his foot on the gas and peeled out, racing forward and jumping from 0-60 MPH in just 10 seconds. Not as fast as the Ferrari could actually accelerate, but he wasn't a professional driver anyway. He only wanted to leave an impression on Phoebe.

The moment the car accelerated, Phoebe's eyes widened. She was pulled back into her seat and gasped as the Ferrari took off, racing down the track as it ramped up to just over 100 MPH, with Jason tearing down the track, his foot holding the gas pedal all the way down.

Jason grinned. He shot a quick glance over at Phoebe, but was surprised to see that her momentary excitement had already disappeared. She was still smiling, but it seemed she had returned to her usual, polite expression.

"I-isn't this exciting?!" Jason prompted. "Isn't it fun?"

Phoebe blushed. She realized he'd seen through her thoughts. "Forgive me, Jason. The first burst of speed startled me a little, but… it's just… not as fast as I thought it would be."

Jason let off the accelerator. He slowed the car to a more comfortable driving speed as he rounded the first bend. Once he returned to a straightaway, he gave Phoebe a quizzical look.

"Not fast enough?" Jason repeated.

The first time he'd ever accelerated, he hadn't even hit 60 MPH before Phoebe had already experienced a tidal wave of emotions. Now they were at 100 MPH and she wasn't even fazed? Was the difference between future and past Phoebe truly that extreme?

Phoebe scratched her chin. "If it were going… maybe… three or four times faster, that would feel more exciting, I think."

Jason was incredulous. "At those speeds, we'd be in real danger if we crashed. I don't want to take such a risk, especially with your life."

Phoebe's smile brightened. "Well, that's sweet of you, Jason. Thank you, and I'm sorry. I should be more appreciative of this 'driving' experience. My manners are truly poor."

"No... it's fine." Jason said, as he eventually slowed the car to a stop. He and Phoebe climbed back out. She barely even gave the car a second glance. It seemed she genuinely wasn't interested in it at all. "I'll see if I can find something faster that can really excite you."

"No need, no need." Phoebe said, waving her hand politely. "I'm sure the others will better appreciate this 'race track' you made."

The problem was, Phoebe had no idea that Jason had told her a white lie earlier. He didn't make the trace track for the others. He'd made it for *her*, thinking she would love to race just like *his* Phoebe had. But she wasn't interested.

It was similar to if Jason had spent weeks thinking up a thoughtful Christmas gift, only for the recipient to barely feign interest in it. He was feeling slightly soul-crushed, but he didn't have a way to verbalize his thoughts without sounding like an asshole. It wasn't Phoebe's fault he had such extreme expectations regarding her interests.

"I'm sure they will." Jason said, smiling tiredly. "Let's go back to the city."

Before he could utter a Word of Power, Phoebe took a step toward him. "Jason, are you okay? I... I'm sorry if my reaction disappointed you. I just... it didn't feel all that fast to me."

"It's my fault." Jason said, his smile fully slipping as he was now feeling somewhat gloomy. "I ruined the fun by overexplaining things to you."

"No, no. I don't think you did." Phoebe said gently, touching his arm. "It was very kind of you to take my feelings into account. If I'd been unprepared, that could have been quite a scary feeling for me."

I know. Jason thought miserably. *Which would have made it more memorable, and left a lasting impact on you, likely translating into a new interest in racing for the foreseeable future.*

He didn't speak these words. He just sighed and shrugged. "I'll see if I can do better next time. Don't worry about it."

"Alright." Phoebe said quietly.

Without another word, Jason teleported himself and Phoebe back to Argent. Once inside the city, Jason split off from Phoebe, allowing her to go about her business.

After he left, Phoebe went back to her domicile. She sat on the bed, a contemplative expression on her face.

"It wasn't fast enough." Phoebe muttered quietly. "If it were faster, a *lot* faster, it could have been truly exciting..."

That thought continued to percolate in her mind for a long, long while...

Part 780: Transition

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

It was drawing toward night-time in Aevum, so the false sun in the sky had dipped below the horizon. Due to the lack of a blue atmosphere such as the one on Earth, Aevum could rapidly darken to the level of nighttime in mere minutes.

Jerome was anxious in a way he hadn't been for a long time. He owed Daisy an apology for exploding at her, but that was barely even on his mind. He kept looking around for his girlfriend, Farrah, and eventually he found out she was back in her dorm room.

Jerome made his way over, and eventually he arrived outside, only to stop in front of her door. He held up his fist, wanting to knock, but he stopped short. He didn't know why she was avoiding him, but they'd been together for a full year, and they usually stuck to each other like glue. He knew for a fact she wasn't absent by accident.

What bothered him the most was... he wasn't sure of the *reason* she'd started avoiding him. Was it his fault? Or, like the Archseer said, was it personal circumstances she didn't want to tell him? Maybe he should just give her some space?

Jerome wrung his hands together. He looked left and right down the hall, but people were still in the gym, likely training or whatever. Nobody had come home just yet. He was all alone, anxiously stepping from the left to the right, then back to the left again, unsure if he should knock on Farrah's door or not.

At least, he thought he was alone. He happened to look back up again, only to spot the last person he wanted to see turn a corner down the hall and start walking toward him.

"Jerome?" Daisy asked, raising an eyebrow as she approached.

"Oh! Uh... shit. Yeah. Hey." Jerome mumbled awkwardly.

Daisy came to a stop several feet away. She paused, then crossed her arms and looked away.

"So, um... I wanted to apol-" Daisy started to say.

"I'm real sorry about what I said before." Jerome quickly interjected before she could finish. "I didn't mean none of that. I mean, you clapped my ears, and that hurt like a

motherfucker, but... I was slappin' you around first. I broke the rules first."

"No, you don't have to apologize." Daisy said quietly. "I know you were just slapping me because you didn't want to hurt me. I got frustrated that I couldn't win, even with my new MindCore, so I used every trick in my pocket to land a hit on you. Unlike you, I didn't pull my punches. Err, my slaps. I'm sorry I hurt you."

"Well. I guess we both fucked up a bit, huh?" Jerome asked, smiling slightly. He fell silent after that and lowered his head.

Daisy looked up. She noticed where he was standing. "What's the matter? You're not going in?"

"Nah, uh, I just... I don't know if I should..." Jerome mumbled. "Your dad, he uh, he told me Farrah was goin' through some stuff. I don't know if I pissed her off or somethin'. Maybe she just needs space?"

"You two live in the same dorm. This is your room as much as hers." Daisy pointed out. "Besides, Farrah likes you a lot. I doubt she's mad at you."

"Yeah? You been usin' your mind-reading on her?" Jerome asked, quickly shooting an accusatory glance Daisy's way.

"...I don't need to read someone's mind to see something so obvious." Daisy retorted.

Jerome felt a little stupid for asking. He always acted defensive when it involved his girlfriend. "Right. Yeah. Sorry."

Another few seconds passed. Daisy bopped her hips from side to side while looking at Jerome, but he still didn't make a move to enter the room.

"You just... gonna stand out here all day?" Daisy pressed.

"I don't know!" Jerome hissed under his breath. "I can't decide what to do!"

"Oh, okay. Then I'll make it easy on you." Daisy said, before abruptly stepping forward, raising a fist, and rapping her knuckles on the door. "Hey Farrah, I brought you something!"

Jerome's heart jumped. He felt a flash of anger, humiliation, and embarrassment. Why would she just charge up and do that?!

But immediately after Daisy said those words... *foop!* She vanished from the spot, teleporting away.

Jerome's blood turned to ice. *That little witch, she did this on purpose!*

But he didn't have time to react. The door opened, and... there was a young man inside Farrah's room who Jerome didn't recognize. He looked a lot like her. Like a twin brother or something.

As soon as the boy looked at Jerome, he froze in place. "J-J-Jer... ome?"

Jerome was taken aback. "The fuck? Who are you? Where's Farrah?"

The teenage boy stared up at Jerome with eyes mixed with all sorts of feelings. He quickly took a step back and started stammering. "Um, I, um, well, Farrah is..."

Jerome was slightly bewildered. "Wait a second... your voice... Farrah? You turned into a guy?"

Her voice hadn't changed at all. It was one big flaw of Farrah's that she was only able to change her face. But this time, her transformation was so physically total that it had taken Jerome by complete surprise. She looked like a wafer-thin teenage boy, a little over eighteen, but she still actually *looked* like a guy. A feminine one with soft hands and smooth skin, but a male nonetheless.

Tears welled up in Farrah's eyes. "I... I didn't know how to tell you, Jerome. I'm s-sorry. I t-t-tried changing... after I talked to Jason, but then I realized I was having a hard time changing back, and I knew you'd be all g-grossed out, so I just tried to avoid you, a-a-and..."

"Whoa, whoa. Grossed out?" Jerome asked, scrunching up his face. "Baby, you thought I'd be grossed out? You use your powers all the time. You know I love that."

"Yeah, but... I only change into other girls..." Farrah said, lowering her eyes. "And becoming a boy is... different."

"Oh. So that's what you mean." Jerome said, resting his fists on his hips. "Man, I thought after a year of bein' together you'd know me better than that. I love YOU, baby! If you wanna turn into a guy once in a while, that's totally fine!"

Farrah looked even more dismal. "Well... I was thinking... I like looking like a boy more than a girl... by a lot. I don't know how to explain it. But I also love you, and that's, um, forbidden. I still *feel* like a girl, too. So now I'm all weird inside. I don't want to be weird."

To his credit, Jerome took her words seriously. "Your parents put all kinds of fucked-up thoughts in your head, baby. We was livin' in America! Not Iran. Where I come from, guys wouldn't even- well... I mean, I guess *most* guys would still find it strange. But hey, fuck 'em! If my girl likes turning into a guy, then I like guys."

"You do?" Farrah asked, blushing slightly. "I was always told boys shouldn't like boys, and girls shouldn't like girls. I don't know how that, um, applies to a girl who becomes a boy... or vice-versa."

"Man, that shit's too complicated for me." Jerome said, waving his hand flippantly. "You're still cute as hell, and you're the girl- I mean, the guy... the person I love. Whaddya gotta say 'bout that?"

"You're really okay with it?" Farrah asked. "Even if I want to look like a boy, you can still think of me as a girl..."

"Hey, for a girl, you look like a really *cute* boy." Jerome said with a big smile. "C'mere, I'll show you I ain't lying."

He took Farrah into his arms, then pulled her in for a kiss. Farrah didn't pull away because she was too excited by his acceptance.

After that, Jerome entered their room and closed the door.

Further details will be omitted.

"Hey, Harold. You here?" Jason asked, as he walked into Harold and Helen's house. He'd already rung their doorbell, but their house was a veritable mansion, with five bedrooms and three bathrooms. He figured it might take them a bit to show up.

Jason fell silent. After nearly a full minute, he heard grumbling down the front hallway. "I'm comin', I'm comin', sheesh, show up at a fella's house in the middle of the damn night..."

Harold shuffled down the hallway, wearing a plaid shirt and some baggy sweats. He looked tired, but not from lack of sleep.

"Did I interrupt anything?" Jason asked, raising an eyebrow.

"Smart-mouthed punk." Harold spat, before revealing a cheeky grin. "What me and the missus do ain't none of yer business. Don't you be usin' them powers to spy, either!"

"I have no interest, and I wouldn't be caught dead doing it." Jason assured him. "Need some coffee to refresh yourself?"

"Coffee. Yeaaap. Sounds good. Let's go yap in the kitchen." Harold muttered.

A few minutes later, Harold was grinding some coffee while Jason sat at the dining table a short distance away.

"This place really is too big." Harold said. "Not like me and Helen are gonna be having kids or guests over."

"I figured I'd leave room... just in case." Jason said. "You never know, and it's a piece of prime real estate."

"Uh huh. Uh huh. So what're you bargin' in here to yap at me about?" Harold asked, as he strained hot water through the ground coffee beans into a cup.

"Well, the big battle against the demons isn't too far away, so there's a couple of things I wanted to talk to you about first." Jason said. "First off, when you're ready, I'd like you to start training the kids, whipping them into shape, and so on."

"Right, right. That was already in the plans." Harold said, as he pulled out some milk and sugar and started doctoring his coffee with a strategic mix to get the flavor he wanted. "Now that me 'n the missus are all set, whatcha need?"

"I'm a very busy man." Jason explained. "I've been training the kids by having them spar, but they've gotten rough and hurt each other's feelings a few times. I'm not sure if I'm going about this the right way."

Harold scoffed as he walked over, sat down, and took his first sip of coffee. "Hurt feelings? What're you tryina do? Train elite soldiers, or raise some mamby-pamby little sissy-bitches?"

"Well... train soldiers..." Jason said slowly.

"Izzat so?" Harold asked. "Well, here's the thing, kid. You've really gotta think about what you actually want out of mah trainin', 'cause there's a difference between trainin' soldiers, warriors, and generals. Soldiers are grunts that go out and storm the battlefield. They're cheap and expendable. The higher-ups don't really care if a bunch die. It's no big deal. Warriors are elite soldiers, trained to go out there and kick real ass. It takes a lotta time 'n investment. If one dies, it's a big loss to the bigwigs."

Harold continued. "Then there's generals. You can't really teach a man to be a general. It's gotta be in their blood. You can teach 'em theory, you can teach 'em strategy, all kinds of other stuff. But then all you end up with is a fella who does everything by the book. Predictable, easy for the enemy to out-think."

Jason nodded. "So what's that have to do with anything?"

"Well, son, I can't teach any of these kids how to be generals." Harold admitted. "I was a dog of war. They sent me out to kill the unkillable. I know about soldiers, and I know about warriors. I can train your kids how to be either one. That's why I'm askin' you now what you want them to be!"

Both men became quiet. Jason fell into thought as he pondered Harold's words.

"It has to be warriors, then." Jason said. "Humans with powers are rare. They're not expendable. They need to be aces in the hole we can use in a pinch. They need to be rock solid in combat and not falter when the going gets tough. Losing even one of these kids would be a huge loss."

"That's what I thought you'd say." Harold said. "The thing is, soldiers need to be trained to follow directions. They've gotta be drilled, drilled, drilled until they operate on instincts. You order them to charge to their deaths, they do it. Warriors, those are sorta similar, but they need to be more free-thinkin' and creative. They solve problems. They need to be smart and quick-witted, as well as havin' the minds of killers. You *sure* these kids are at that level?"

Jason grimaced. He wasn't sure of that, not at all. Aside from his daughter, the teenagers in Aevum were lackadaisical, had little in the way of survival instincts, and were definitely part of a generation that had grown up with technology that made their lives infinitely easier than their predecessors. Sasha had complained multiple times that the time differential meant she couldn't chat with her friends back on Earth, just as one example.

Jerome was probably the 'hardest' of the Lowborn, since he'd led a tough life. He'd been in plenty of scraps, and he knew how to fight. That was more than the rest of them could say. But even he hadn't taken another man's life. Only Daisy had, and under her uncle's direction, she had ended many...

"Well. Not really." Jason eventually admitted.

"Good." Harold said, taking a metaphorical step back. "It's good you can admit that. Look, you see these kids with special abilities, and you think that means they should all be wizards 'n witches, out there slingin' voodoo and shit at the demons. I get it, that's the obvious choice. Maybe that's even what a smart guy would choose, but truth is, you're a fighter by necessity, not by choice."

"I'm not a fighter?" Jason asked, directing a strange look Harold's way. "I've killed... a lot of demons. Among other enemies."

"Right. But you ain't done anything involving killin' 'cause you *liked* it, and that's the difference." Harold said. "Nothin' wrong with a leader who only fights when needed. But the thing is, everything you're doing is 'cause you think it *has* to be done, and it goes against your instincts. Since you lack those instincts, you're full of blind spots only outsiders can see."

Harold sipped some more coffee, swishing it around his teeth. It seemed he really liked the taste.

"Alright, let's get serious a bit. I know the powers these kids have. I did a lot of readin' up on their files. If need be, I can whip any of 'em into competent fighters, even great ones. But that's a waste of talent. This Sasha girl, I bet we could come up with all sorts of creative uses for her powers, once she masters 'em. If you wanna kill demons, that's what the boys in green are for. That's what guns are for. You've got a one-of-a-kind creative talent in Sasha! Why have her be one of a million grunts when she can be on the backlines, supporting the meatheads?"

Jason nodded. A similar thought had occurred to him before. "You think her Alchemy powers are wasted on the frontlines? I'm sure she could do more damage than even a thousand soldiers."

"So can a nuke." Harold scoffed. "But y'know what's even better than putting a little girl out there who can fight Demon Emperors? Having her use her powers to make a million men fight Demon Emperors. Y'see what I'm saying?"

Once again, Jason nodded. Harold's logic was sound.

"Take a lookie here." Harold said, reaching into his back pocket. He pulled out a folded piece of paper and handed it to Jason. "Been chewin' on this a few weeks now."

Jason opened the paper. Inside, there was a short list of all the teenagers in Aevum, including Daisy, listing their abilities and the roles they could be good at. They were also assigned grades, like they were in school or something.

Daisy Hiro: Telekinesis (A), Healing (?), Teleportation (A+), Animal Reflexes (B), Enhanced Body (F)...

Special skills: Assassination, counter-terrorism, athletics, hand-to-hand combat, gunmanship...

Best roles: Hunter-Killer, Silent Assassin, Decapitation Striker.

Jason scratched his chin. He already knew most of this stuff, but Daisy's background skills were a little new to him. He'd naturally spoken with his daughter many times, but she was always somewhat evasive regarding her childhood. It seemed she didn't want to tell her father exactly what she'd gone through. Jason realized this was either because she didn't want to make him sad, or she didn't want to enrage him. What little he'd seen from the flash of her memories had nearly driven him insane with fury. He could only imagine how he'd react if he knew the rest.

"How'd you learn all this about my daughter?" Jason questioned.

"She told me." Harold said. "Actually, no. She told Helen, who told me. She seems to like Helen a lot."

"I see." Jason said quietly.

He moved further down the list.

Jerome Nguyen: Enhanced Strength (B), Growing Power (A+), Enhanced Durability (C-)...

Special skills: Street fighting, hand-to-hand combat, thievery, scrounging, makeshift repairs...

Best roles: Assault Squad, Base Assault, Elite Takedown Ops.

To Jason, all of this looked about right. Jerome and Daisy's roles lined up exactly with what Jason imagined they would be good at. He read through the rest of the info on all the other teenagers as well.

Brian Bozzard: Flame Manipulation (C+), Flight (F).

Special skills: Diplomacy, fine dining, brewing tea.

Best roles: Metallurgist, Energy Producer, Airspace Assault.

Nadia Chasky: Extreme Intelligence (A+), Big Brain (A+), Very Smart (A+).

Special skills: Thinking hard, using her brain, martial arts.

Best roles: Inventor, Predictions Analyst, Elite Teacher.

Farrah Lapis: Shapeshifting (D+), Cooking (C).

Special skills: Baking cookies, entertainment, giving compliments.

Best roles: Infiltration, Spying, Special Agent.

Sasha Popov: Alchemy (?), Tailoring (A+), Fashion Design (B+?).

Special skills: Designing clothes, fashionista.

Best roles: Armorer, weaponsmith, special materials creator, deep-earth miner.

Marco Kamau: Making Time Bubbles (B?).

Special skills: Cowardice, running away, hiding.

Best roles: Olympic Sprinter? House Robber?

* * *

Jason read through Harold's evaluations of the teenagers with approval. Aside from Marco, who Harold didn't really seem to have much understanding of, he had pretty good ideas for all the rest of them.

"Airspace Assault for Brian?" Jason asked.

"The kid can fly, and he can shoot fireballs... but I don't think his fireballs are all that impressive." Harold grumbled. "Better to give that boy a sniper rifle and train him to pop a head from a click off the ground."

Jason shrugged. It wasn't a bad idea at all. But unlike Harold, Jason had known Beelzebub. He believed Brian could reach the same heights as mankind's once-fiercest enemy.

He looked at the list again. "Deep-earth mining for Sasha?"

"I dunno. It just seemed sensible to me." Harold said dismissively. "I've gots a good feeling about that little lady."

"No ideas for Marco, though?" Jason pressed. "None at all?"

"I... don't really get the boy's power, and he's too quiet for m'liking." Harold replied. "I told you mah list wasn't finished yet. Maybe I'll add more for him later."

"No, that's fine." Jason said. "I have my own ideas."

One entry on the list really caught Jason's eye. "You wrote here that you think Nadia would make a great teacher. Why, because she's smart?"

"Smart people don't always make good teachers. But Nadia's special." Harold said with a smile. "That pretty little lady's good at 'comprehension'. Any ninny with a two-bit tutorin' book can teach a fella how to count numbers. But she actually *gets* everything she learns on a deep level. You should be havin' her teach others, 'cause she'll know how to dumb stuff down to their level."

Jason was skeptical. "Nadia's talents are so beyond the ordinary, she should be inventing powerful technology all the time. That's the most effective use of her time."

"Having one smarty-pants is good, but if she can teach a hundred others, that's way better, innit?" Harold asked.

Jason slowly nodded. He had to admit, Harold was making a good point. It would be better to have 100 Nadias accelerating Aevum's progress than just one.

But... still. Asking her to spend time teaching others, after what she'd been through? Jason wasn't about to do that. Maybe later.

Jason chatted with Harold. After the two of them talked about the teenagers a bit more, Harold lightly slapped the table.

"Alrighty, then! I'll start training them once you've finished putting those mind-thingies in their heads. Maybe once these kids are a bit smarter, they'll be able to follow directions a little better."

"That's all I ask of you." Jason said, smiling. "I'm sure you'll do a great job, Harold. And also... there's, uh, one last thing."

"Yeah?" Harold asked. "What's that?"

"It's about the upcoming War in Heaven." Jason said, his smile slipping. "I... I don't think I'm going to deploy you. Or any of the teenagers."

"You're not??" Harold asked, bewildered. "Wait, wait, wait. Ain't that why you gave me this super-strong body? To kick demon ass?"

"Yes... but now isn't the time." Jason explained slowly. "Right now, I'm trying to play a long, elaborate trick on the demons. I call it Project Great Deceiver. I won't go into the specifics, but basically, I need the demons to think we humans are a lot weaker than we really are. They already know we have two Trueborn Heroes. What do you think they'll do when the legendary Captain America comes back from the dead? Even just seeing you will spike their alarm levels dramatically."

"Ah... I see. Yeah, that makes sense..." Harold muttered. "So you're keepin' me in the back pocket in case of emergencies?"

"That's right." Jason said. "In fact, I need to get Helen outfitted with a MindCore as soon as possible. Your wife will be assisting the Daughter of Heaven, building stuff for her. The sooner she has her MindCore, the better."

Jason had already spoken to Helen about her MindCore previously, and had presented her the options. As expected, she had chosen the GenesisFrame, like him and Sasha. That meant once all the MindCores were installed, there would be two more people with MindCores similar to Jason's... well, except theirs would be way more advanced. Jason would need to upgrade his or risk falling way behind.

"I'll install Helen's MindCore, then Sasha's right afterward." Jason said. "The two of them picked the same one, so I might as well. After that, I'll do Brian, then Farrah, and finally... Marco."

"Marco." Harold repeated, shaking his head wryly as he took a sip of coffee. "Let's hope that kid finally amounts to somethin' with a bigger brain boosting him. Right now, he just ain't worth talkin' about."

"I guess not." Jason said, not entirely comfortable badmouthing a kid who wasn't even present with the two of them.

He concluded his discussion with Harold, then vanished from the spot, leaving the old man to finish up his coffee.

After a few minutes, Harold had drained his cup.

"Shit." Harold cursed. "What was I thinkin'? Now I've got all this energy and can't git back to sleep. Hmm, maybe the missus is in the mood to get frisky, eh? Heh heh heh..."

Harold darted back into the bedroom, knowing soon he and Helen would have to part ways, at least temporarily. Might as well make some new memories while they still had the chance.

Part 781: Neon Genesis

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Two weeks passed inside Aevum, slightly less than an hour in the real world. In that time, Daisy trained relentlessly with Phoebe, the two of them rapidly growing more proficient at unleashing the potential within their enhanced minds.

Phoebe was, without a doubt, ten times stronger than Daisy. Her body was more durable. Her punches hit harder. Her throws went further. But Daisy had a huge advantage in her psionic powers that allowed her to level the playing field.

At the same time, Phoebe couldn't help but notice that her new benefactor, Lord Elrin, had remained unusually quiet ever since Daisy's awakening. Once in a while, he might say a few words to her, but despite her being his potential Inheritor, he didn't seem interested in actually teaching her anything. Instead, he would drop vague hints, telling her that the powers of the Sphinx were far, far more profound than she could ever imagine. He kept encouraging her to read books when she wasn't training and learn about the modern world.

He especially seemed interested in having her learn about biology and the different species on Earth. He never said why, leaving Phoebe perplexed, but she felt he was wiser than she could fathom, so she obeyed dutifully.

In order to beat Phoebe, Daisy had to constantly get creative. Her mother was a monster! Anytime Daisy used her psychic powers to suppress or trick Phoebe, the former Knight of Camelot found a new way to adapt. Her adaptability was inexplicable, as if she possessed a wellspring of knowledge she had to keep unearthing. And forcing Phoebe to her knees required a lot of planning on Daisy's part too, as she had to be as creative as possible to best her mother.

But then, two weeks later, Jason announced it was finally time. He took Sasha and Helen into the infirmary, and everyone in Aevum held their breaths. Daisy's soul-surgery had not resulted in any anomalies, besides a mild sensory overload at the start. It seemed the days of horrific side effects had finally come to an end, but everyone was worried all the same.

Nobody was more anxious than Harold.

"Boy, oh boy. I tell ya h'wat. That boy better not screw up my missus' head. I'll whoop him. I will!" Harold grumbled to himself, loudly enough for the others to hear. "She better come out the same dame as before, but smarter. If she starts actin' all screwy, I'mma whip that boy's ass til it blisters! He ain't never gonna forget it, I tells ya that!"

Everyone was sitting out in the park across from the infirmary, waiting for the verdict. Daisy laughed nervously. She was a little intimidated by Harold, because she could feel his Heroic Aura was much stronger than hers. To the other teens, he was a funny old man who said funny things, but Daisy was always aware he was a battle-hardened warrior who had killed innumerable soldiers during the Second World War. He was not to be taken lightly.

Brian had a thoughtful look on his face. Marco seemed as down in the dumps as always. Daisy wasn't sure why, but ever since coming to Aevum, he'd become even more reclusive than he already was. He joined in on social events, but he usually kept to himself and didn't say much. His body language made it clear he was feeling a little despondent.

After chewing on her lip for a while, Daisy slid over to Marco.

"Hey, Marco." She said, not sure how to break the ice.

Marco was sitting on the grass, his knees pulled up with his chin resting on them, and his left arm wrapped around his legs. He was mindlessly picking at the grass with his right hand, either bored out of his mind, or living in his head entirely.

"...Huh?" Marco asked, blinking his eyes. He looked up to see Daisy was sitting next to him. He hadn't even noticed her arrival.

"I said 'hey'." Daisy repeated. "Are you doing okay?"

"Oh. Yeah. I'm... fine." Marco mumbled, looking back at the ground. He continued to pick at the grass.

"Are you worried about your future MindCore?" Daisy asked. "You've been awfully quiet lately. Quieter than usual."

"Worried?" Marco repeated. "No. Not really. It's not like it will matter."

Daisy blinked. "What do you mean? You think the ability to predict stuff won't be useful? My dad said he used something similar in the future to beat the demons' butts!"

"Yeah. But your dad has strong magical powers. I can snap my fingers and make stuff disappear for a second or two." Marco said, his tone glum. "What good will a MindCore

do for someone as useless as me?"

Daisy opened her mouth to reply, but her heart dropped when she heard Marco mutter a few extra words. "I'm useless. I shouldn't even be here."

"Whoa, whoa." Daisy said quietly, trying not to draw attention to them from the others. "Marco, come on, now. My dad said that at the very least, your power will allow him to make huge advances in technology and rapidly advance Aevum. Don't you think that's kind of incredible?? Even if that's the *only* thing your powers do, that's still going to let you assist the entirety of humanity!"

"Great." Marco mumbled. "I get turned into a finger-snapping machine. Over and over, snapping my fingers to rapidly speed up your dad's timeline. Really incredible stuff- why does he even need me for that anyway?"

Marco turned his head to look at Daisy with an accusatory glance. "No, like seriously. He's already got that weird black hole time-freeze place anyway. I'm sure if he uses his powers he can replicate mine, no problem."

"Dad already told you it has a lot of side effects that your powers don't." Daisy said, her voice soft. "Marco, maybe you don't believe in your powers, but I do. I think they're really unique, and if you experimented with them more-"

"I don't *want* to experiment with them more." Marco hissed under his breath. "I don't want to be a part of any of this. Killing demons. Killing humans. It's all just... *evil*! I want to be a normal guy, go to college, meet a nice girl, live a decent life. Instead, I got stuck with some magical ability that could make me kill people if I ever absent-mindedly snap my fingers in tune to a song. Do you know how scary that thought is? I've got ADHD! I lose focus all the time! I'm a walking bomb, and a danger to everyone around me. And the best use we can come up with is using my ability to supercharge the fucking Human Weapons Program."

Daisy fell silent. She looked away.

At this point, she understood that Marco's concerns went deeper than she expected. Marco thought his abilities were useless because Jason's word magic could replicate them, but he also thought they were dangerous just because if he ever snapped his fingers without thinking, he might kill someone.

On top of that, he was not a fighter. He didn't want to hurt or kill people. As such, he placed no value on learning combat training, and when Daisy thought of his sparring sessions with other people, calling Marco's performance 'half-hearted' would be a serious understatement. He couldn't spar against the girls because he had major hangups with hitting women, and he stood no chance against the other men. Even Brian would hand Marco his ass, and Brian wasn't exactly a combat expert. It went without saying that Jason, Harold, and Jerome were unbeatable.

That made Daisy wonder... was Marco possibly feeling emasculated because he was surrounded by men who were all way stronger and more powerful than him?

She... didn't know how to breach such a topic. If she spoke incorrectly, it might worsen his mood. She suspected it could be the truth, but short of reading his mind, she didn't have an easy way to verify her conjecture.

Daisy and Marco had been friends for a long time. Were they best friends? No. But they talked. She knew he had been a quiet guy beforehand, but he didn't seem actively miserable in the past, just a little shy and withdrawn. The fact his attitude had declined this far had started to seriously worry her.

Before Daisy could press him further on the subject, Brian's voice rang out. "They're done!"

Daisy and Marco looked up in unison. Across the street, four people left the infirmary. Jason looked exhausted. Nadia seemed the same as ever, and she was wearing her PepScan to keep an eye on the mental states of the two people who had just had their Mind Realms operated on.

Sasha and Helen had looks of awe on their face. As they stepped out into the daylight, they both winced, not from the brightness of the outside world, but from their MindCores feeding them all manner of crazy thoughts. Sasha stopped just outside the door and started touching the infirmary walls, muttering to herself about the 'construction material imperfections', while Helen took a few steps toward her overjoyed husband and frowned in disgust as she looked at his clothes.

"Goodness, Harold!" Helen cried. "I can't believe I didn't notice the state of your outfit! Wrinkles everywhere, a smudge of egg on the collar! You can't leave the house looking like a slob!"

Harold was all smiles, happy to see his wife come out in one piece. But he did a double take when she started criticizing his outfit. He looked down and... he couldn't even see the smudge she was talking about. As for the wrinkles in his clothes, why would he care about such a silly thing?

"Huh?" Harold grunted. "Helen, what in the dickens are you talkin' about? You told me to wear this shirt..."

Sasha walked over to Helen. She looked even more appalled than Helen at his state. "Oh, you're right, miss Helen! It's dreadful! That color combination doesn't go together at all! You should let me take a look at his wardrobe. I'll help you coordinate several good outfits that go together."

"I can't believe I let him go outside without at least ironing his shirts." Helen said, pressing a palm over her eyes in embarrassment. "To think I was so blind before!"

Jerome walked over to Harold's side. He looked the old man up and down. "Why are you two actin' like that? Ain't nothing wrong with the old man's clothes. He looks fine to me."

"*Fine*, you say?" Sasha asked. Her face turned a little green when she looked at Jerome's outfit. "Let's not... hear any opinions about fashion from you, okay, Jerome? A black T-shirt and sweatpants? You're practically wearing pajamas! I'll need to work on your wardrobe as well! I can't believe you have the face to walk outside dressed like that!"

Question marks popped up over the heads of everyone present. Phoebe looked as if she was gazing at aliens for the first time. Daisy seemed as though she couldn't recognize Sasha at all. Farrah looked as if she were going to leap to the defense of her boyfriend.

"Ooookay, guys. Let's all calm down for a minute." Jason said, walking between the two groups with a tired expression covering his face. "Sasha, Helen, I warned you about this. You need to dial down the sensitivity of your MindCores a little more. There's too much stimuli for you out here. You're starting to sound like crazy people."

"Crazy? I'm not crazy." Helen said. "It's just that there's all these problems with the world and I can finally see them now! We have to do something to fix them. There's bad design everywhere!"

"People have a bad sense of fashion and that should be a CRIME!" Sasha added. "In fact, it is a crime... against humanity!"

Jason wanted to facepalm. Now he understood what a lunatic he had sounded like when he first got his GenesisFrame. No wonder everyone had looked at him as if a leech had latched onto his brain.

After a few minutes, Jason helped the two women adjust their MindCore power levels. Over time, they would slowly dial them up as Jason had, using their full brains more and more. Daisy had hers on at 80% power all the time now, only dialing it up to 100% when it was time to fight. Nadia, from the start, had hers on at 100% and never turned it down, but she was a special case due to her cerebral power, and the fact she had 70+ virtual years of experience with it locked at 100%.

"Alright," Jason said, as the two newest MindCore users started getting used to their new mental abilities. "Sasha, I'll be having you spend some time with Nadia to learn more about your MindCore. Helen, for the next few months, I'm going to have you read, read, read up on all sorts of books."

Helen nodded. She'd already been given a huge assortment of books from Jason, who had downloaded most of Earth's knowledge into his head and made organized copies of the information in book form at for her. He'd created a library not dissimilar to Solomon's future library in the Hall of Heroes, but admittedly the quality was much, much worse. Solomon had billions more years of memories and knowledge stored in his crown, so his books were a lot more thorough.

"You want me to aid the Daughter of Heaven, right?" Helen asked.

"That's right." Jason said. "You need to become proficient in technology as quickly as possible. You'll be able to pass your knowledge on to Heaven's Daughter, accelerating her fighting capabilities. You have the same potential powers as her, but it's up to you if you also want to become a fighter or not. Your MindCore isn't geared toward combat, but you're still way smarter than any average human. If you put your mind to it, you could become equally fearsome."

Helen didn't look interested. "Heaven's Daughter is a good friend, so I'm happy to help her. But me, fighting? I will pass. I've had more than enough fighting in my time, having waited on Harold to return during World War II."

Harold nodded. He lovingly wrapped an arm around Helen's shoulders. "My dame ain't the fightin' type. But she's sharp as a tack. You done made a good choice, juicin' up her brain like that. I'm sure she'll be a real asset moving forward."

Jason nodded. He looked at the others. "Now that Helen and Sasha have successfully had their MindCores installed, I plan to move onto the next candidates soon. Brian, you're next. Then Farrah, and finally, Marco."

"So soon?" Brian asked. "Not that I am complaining, of course, but don't you usually space these out over weeks?"

"We're running out of time." Jason said. "It's nightfall on Earth in about four Aevum-months. More specifically, it's dusk. We don't know if the demons will wait until full pitch-black nighttime arrives, or if they'll attack when the sun dips below the horizon. If it's the former, than we have four months. If it's the latter, up to five months."

"Remember," Nadia interjected, "we don't only need to install your MindCores, but train you in how to use them. If we wait too long between install sessions, it might give the newest users time to acclimate to their Cores and for us to make sure there are no aberrations, but it also means cutting your training time down."

There was a moment of silence. Jason chewed his lip.

"One other things. I'm... not going to be sending any of you out to fight the demons."

"What? You're not??" Brian asked, bewildered. "Then why the rush?"

"Because the second War in Heaven is going to change everything." Jason explained. "I won't have much free time once the demons finally attack. Even with the extreme time dilation here, I'm going to be moving like crazy to try and handle things on the battlefield. You might think I have all the time in the world, but a lot can happen in real-world seconds. Even if I have hundreds of extra seconds to react, a few minutes of complacency can get people killed."

Harold nodded and smiled. He appreciated that Jason was looking at the bigger picture to try and save lives. He also especially liked that Jason was being proactive and not procrastinating until deadlines were near. Better to give himself a lot of buffer time than run the risk of catastrophic screw-ups. Too many nimrods in the military had treated soldiers as expendable in Harold's time. He wouldn't work under fools like that ever again.

"In the meantime," Jason continued. "Harold is going to start training everyone with a MindCore. Much of the work will not be combat related, surprisingly. I need to rest for a few days, then I'll move on to the rest of you."

Nadia turned to look at Jerome. "I'm sure you're wondering why we haven't talked about your MindCore yet."

Jerome blinked. "Yeah? Jason didn't mention me at all."

"We could give you one." Nadia said. "But... I talked to Jason, and we have an idea we wanted to run past you."

Jerome was surprised. They weren't going to give him a MindCore? Did that mean they thought it would be a waste? Was he too much of a meathead?

Jason seemed to read his mind. "It's not what you think. I've just noticed that Phoebe already seems to have something on the level of a QuantumReflex MindCore in her head, and she's really strong. It felt like if we gave you a QuantumReflex, you'd just be doing the same thing as Phoebe. Better or worse? Doesn't really matter. We want to turn everyone here into a unique powerhouse with their own arsenal and bags of tricks."

"Tricks ain't really my style." Jerome said, his tone bland. "I like punching shit. Beating the fuck out of motherfuckers."

"Come with us." Jason said.

Like this, Jason, Nadia, and Jerome vanished from the spot, leaving everyone behind. Even Daisy was caught offguard.

"The heck? Where are they going? What's my dad planning?" Daisy asked.

Harold shrugged. "Kid didn't tell me nothin'. Whatever, let's git on home, Helen. Time to bury your nose in them books. Leave the plannin' and stratemagizin' to these young'uns."

He and Helen departed. The others were left to surround Sasha and excitedly start asking her all sorts of questions about her new mental abilities.

* * *

Jason and Nadia whisked Jerome off to a hidden underground area elsewhere on Aevum, far outside the city limits. They materialized inside a steel bunker with bright floodlights attached to the ceiling a hundred-feet above. When Jerome looked around, he was startled.

"Robots?" Jerome asked.

"Not just any robots. These are, to be frank, copies of various powerful demons." Jason said, gesturing to the silvery-metallic mannequins standing at attention in the center of the room. "They're... not as strong as the real deal. But their strengths combined are pretty respectable. They'll beat your ass if you're not prepared."

"You want me to fight these things?" Jerome asked, bewildered.

"Yes. But not yet. That's not the fun surprise." Jason said, smiling cheekily. "Turn around."

Jerome did just that. He turned around and gasped. There was a giant metal robot behind him, ten feet tall, but its chest was open. It was humanoid. It looked 'clunky'. It looked like it was made of parts welded together sloppily. It looked rusty and old.

But it also looked really badass. It reminded him of old sci-fi stories of automatons from outer space.

"This is what we've been working on." Jason said. "More specifically, Nadia crafted the schematics. It's a special type of Power Armor made just for you. I call it H-Boy v1. Hop inside and you'll see."

Jerome nodded. He walked over to the H-Boy and looked it up and down. It was a lot bigger than him, and it looked like it weighed several tons. It had spiked fists, giant fingers, huge and wide feet to provide stability, and a circular 'orb' head with hundreds of tiny pinprick-sized holes, likely to provide vision to its operator.

Jerome hefted himself up toward its open chest cavity. He clumsily turned around to get in backward, but he banged the back of his head on a sharp piece of metal and cried out in pain. The impact even drew blood.

Jason healed Jerome. It wasn't much of an injury, so it was trivial for him.

It took Jerome a few minutes to stuff his legs down into the H-Boy's legs. He felt a little disoriented, like he was standing two feet taller than before, and the ground looked *wrong*. He wasn't used to being this 'tall'.

"Alright." Jason said. "The H-Boy is... special. It doesn't have a power source. It only moves under your strength. You have to move it yourself."

"Huh?" Jerome asked, bewildered. "You couldn't like, add a fancy computer system or whatever? Does it shoot like missiles and lasers and shit?"

"Nope. Nothing like that." Jason said. "Let's start with the basics. Try to get it moving."

Jason didn't explain what he meant. He gave Jerome no instructions, so Jerome had to put his arms inside the robot's arms and pull the cockpit shut, drenching himself in darkness. The interior was uncomfortably warm, and Jerome already started to sweat from the slow heat buildup his body was producing in such a closed space.

"Make it move..." Jerome muttered to himself. "The fuck does he mean? What, like I gotta move this rusty piece of shit myself? Um... I guess I just lift my leg then?"

Jerome did that. He hooked his foot into the 'shoe' of the power armor. Then he tried lifting.

"Huuuk! Come on! Move, move, you piece of garbage! Grrrgh! Jesus fucking Christ, there's no way this fucking thing only weighs a few tons!"

Jerome strained and strained. He felt the power armor shift slightly, but the movement was so small it couldn't really be counted as 'moving' it except in the most literal sense.

"God damn, motherfucker." Jerome cursed. "Move, you cocksucker! How fucking heavy is this tin can?! Am I supposed to use it to fight demons?! Maybe if I try moving the arms..."

Jerome wiggled his right hand around inside the power armor, fumbling to try and find controls. He eventually felt some sort of grabbable 'bar', and he wrapped his fingers around it.

"Son of a BITCH, what the fucking fuck am I supposed to do?!" Jerome roared. "Fucking lift, or turn, or even twitch a finger! Do SOMETHING!!"

Outside the power armor, Nadia's expression was blank. "Should we... tell him?"

"No, no. It's funnier this way." Jason said. "Besides, if he gives up right away, he won't have the mindset to handle adversity. Let him cuss a bunch. It's good for the soul to get the anger out anyway."

A slight smile twitched at the edge of Nadia's lips. "You're such an asshole sometimes."

Jerome struggled, roared with rage, and struggled some more. Every so often, the power armor would slightly twitch, but never did it manage to make any substantial movements.

Thirty minutes passed. Jason scratched his head. "You're... *sure* you set it to the lowest resistance to start, right?"

"Pretty sure." Nadia said. "Don't worry. He'll figure it out eventually. In the meantime, can we get some lunch? I'm hungry."

"Me too. That surgery was exhausting." Jason said with a chuckle.

He whisked Nadia away, leaving Jerome behind.

All the while, Jerome kept cursing, cursing, and cursing some more.

"Fuck you, Jason! You piece of shit! This is a trick! This shit don't work! Lift your finger, motherfucker! Lift it! LIFT! Hrrgh, HRRRRGH!! God DAMN why don't this bucket of bolts MOVE?!"

"JASOOOON!!"

Part 782: Jason's Echo

January 29th, 2021. Aevum.

Jason and Nadia had a quiet dinner together. They didn't do this often, and there were zero romantic overtones to the interaction. Jason made sure to stay strictly professional with Nadia. He was well aware of her love for him, and he didn't want to do anything to encourage her. He hoped, with time, her inclinations toward him would fade away. He also hoped for the same thing with Catherine too, but whether or not that would actually happen was anyone's guess.

Jason had already guessed that Nadia never deleted her mind-clone of him. Not too long ago, she even admitted as much. Thus, when sitting near her, Jason felt a faint sense of discomfort. Just like Hope and Fiona, there was another clone nearby, a copy of Jason he couldn't interact with. Ever since Nadia fessed up to the copy's continuing existence, it felt like a barrier between the two of them had weakened somewhat.

Jason knew she was pushing all her feelings for him onto her Fake Jason. That helped her cope with the fact she couldn't be with the 'real' Jason. But personally, Jason himself wasn't sure what being 'real' meant. Was Hope 'fake' just because he was a clone? Of course not. He was real. So was Fiona.

Even if the mind-wiped Jason in her head only existed as an incorporeal lifeform, Jason had already started to think of his unknowable clone as a real person. In the Wordsmith's eyes, the distinction between 'real' and 'fake' life forms had blurred a lot over his lifetime. Humans and robots were as real to him as cats and dogs... especially now that he knew even *those* could talk.

Nadia spun her fork around some noodles. She scooped them into her mouth and smiled. She wasn't looking at Jason, but she seemed really happy about something.

It took a moment, but eventually Jason's curiosity won out.

"Something funny?" Jason asked, cutting off a chunk of steak and forking it into his mouth. He chewed the savory meat slowly, relishing the taste.

Nadia's smile widened a little. Then it disappeared. She blinked her eyes and looked up at Jason, slightly dazed. "What?"

"You were smiling." Jason said. "I thought maybe the... other me... said something funny."

"The other you." Nadia repeated. She blushed a little, then looked down at the table with a smile. "Yes. He is pretty funny sometimes. But no, that's not why I was smiling."

She paused for a few seconds longer than felt necessary.

"I was, um, talking to him. I realized it could be a little weird always calling him Mental Jason or whatever. So he suggested that he should have his own name, like Hope did. I thought his choice was kind of cute."

Jason tensed up a little. "His own name, huh?"

Seeing the look on Jason's face, Nadia's smile faded a little. "Yes, okay? It only makes sense."

"He's aware of my existence. Does that mean he knows what he is, what his reality is?" Jason questioned.

This was the first time Jason had really spoken to Nadia about the clone in her head since a few weeks before. Now that the topic was out in the open, he thought he might as well learn more about her mental situation.

Nadia sighed. She spun more noodles around her fork. "Well, yes. He knows he's a mental clone. He also knows that I erased his memories of a wife and kids. He doesn't mind, because he's never known them. They're strangers to him, no different from people living down the road. Slightly familiar at a glance, but zero emotional connection. So he's not wallowing in depression or anything like that. And he's quite happy to live inside my MindCore, given all the amenities."

"Amenities?" Jason repeated, slightly puzzled.

"Of course. I can make models of anyone alive, now that I'm not trapped in my simulation. He's always in there, playing games, chatting with people, or even training in battle against the Demon Emperors, like Ose."

"Oh. Huh." Jason muttered. He looked thoughtful as he pondered this new information.

Nadia noticed his negativity lessening. "That's right. Also, the time dilation inside my Mind Realm is quite extreme. He's been in there for many many hundreds of years. He's

probably older in my simulated universe than you are in the real one, and that's not counting his years of knowledge taken from your life in Aevum."

She seemed to be bragging, but at the same time, there was a lot of warmth in Nadia's voice. Jason smiled.

"At least you're treating your Copy Jason well." He conceded.

"Well, that's the thing." She said. "He doesn't want to be known as Copy-Jason anymore, or whatever else. He told me that from now on, you should refer to him as... Echo."

Jason blinked. "Echo? Is he for real?"

"Jason-Echo. Yes." Nadia said seriously. "He'd like for you to refer to and think of him as just Echo in the future, okay?"

Jason thought for a moment. Truthfully, he thought Hope had been a kind of stupid name at first, but Echo seemed even dumber. Was he just *really* bad at naming things? It was no wonder Phoebe forced him into letting her name the kids.

Immediately, he thought of Hero City and what a lame name that had been to. Who the hell was he to judge what his mental clone called himself?

"Alright. Echo it is, then." Jason said.

A long pause followed. Jason chewed his lip. "Does Echo... want a real body?"

"What?" Nadia asked, her breath catching slightly. "Are you offering to make him one?"

"Well yeah." Jason said. "I think it's... only fair. I'd be lying if I said that after Hope I wasn't really apprehensive about doing it. But... it feels wrong to leave Echo locked up in your head. I also can't talk to him at all. I can't get a feel for the guy."

Nadia seemed hesitant. She closed her eyes and seemed to enter into an internal discussion with Echo. When she opened her eyes again, her expression was one of disbelief.

"Echo said.. no." Nadia said, enunciating each word carefully. "He said he has no interest in... meatspace. He likes living in the paradise of his wife's mind."

"Wife." Jason repeated, causing the word to hang in the air for several uncomfortable seconds. "You married the guy stuck in your head? I don't remember being invited to the

wedding."

Nadia didn't have a witty retort. She simply poked at her food and lowered her head.

"It... felt like the next logical step." She muttered softly.

Jason didn't press the issue. "Alright. Well, if Echo wants to pop out into the real world, I'll make accommodations for him. He can always use one of my Dronesmiths as a backup."

Nadia didn't accept or deny his offer. It seemed Echo had zero interest in such an arrangement.

Jason wondered just what sort of 'him' she had cultivated inside her mind. He's only been living in the Earth era for about a year, counting time dilation. The fact Echo was hundreds of years older made him feel a weird disconnection. Was Echo just living it up, going on roller coaster rides, beating the shit out of virtual Demon Emperors, and having mind-sex with Nadia whenever he wanted?

Shit. Maybe he was. If it wasn't Nadia but instead Phoebe, Jason might even be tempted to taste the fruits of such an arrangement.

The table fell silent. Man and woman ate their food, with Nadia occasionally smiling to herself as she mentally chatted with her invisible husband. All the while, Jason felt a strange coldness settle over his body.

He thought about Daisy. He thought about Timothy.

But most of all, he thought about Phoebe.

Time had not healed the wound. He still missed her. The pain was just as fresh as the day he'd hugged her corpse in his arms.

He wanted his wife back. He never stopped thinking about her. The fact Echo was allowed to simply forget her and live a happy life inside Nadia's MindCore secretly ate at him. He felt bad for what Echo had lost, but he envied his copy for the pain he didn't have to endure.

Sometimes, the mental pain was so bad that Jason wanted to end his life. He couldn't do that though. Not while he still had his father and daughter around. Not while the younger Phoebe was here... maybe he could kindle a spark with her. Or maybe it wasn't the right thing to do. He just didn't know.

Jason slowly ate his food, finding that even though it was technically delicious, it was like sand in his mouth without his wife there to enjoy it with him.

All the while, Nadia closed her eyes, unaware of Jason's inner thoughts.

* * *

Inside Nadia's MindCore, there was a vast simulated reality. It wasn't the same as the real world, not even by a little bit. Anyone who entered it would be fully aware it was artificial. Physics didn't function the way they did in realspace. The 'primary space' Nadia typically existed in was like a massive space station suspended in a starless void, with a thousand roads that spiraled off into orbs of light that led to other simulated realities with their own laws of physics.

It resembled a massive mechanical spiderweb, with threads spinning out in hundreds of directions.

Nadia was the owner of her MindCore, but she was frequently busy in the real world. She often had to think about things outside the sphere of her inner mind. As such, the administrator of her MindCore who kept it maintained and running was none other than Jason-Echo, also known simply as Echo.

Echo was Jason. At a glance, that much was obvious. But *who* a man was had more to do with the life he'd lived and the thoughts in his head than his mere personality. A man who had been violently mugged would be a drastically different person than a version of him who beat the hell out of his mugger. This fact was what exemplified the differences between Jason and Echo.

Unlike Jason, Echo did not have any memories or attachments toward Phoebe, Daisy, or Timothy. However, this did not mean he was a lobotomized clone of the real Jason. In fact, Nadia had withheld an important fact from Jason... Echo still had all the memories of his former life available to him. If he desired, he could even integrate them back into his mind as if they had never left.

But he didn't. To Echo, those memories were like videos recorded by a completely different person. He had flipped through them in the past. He knew of Phoebe's existence, and he had witnessed the tragedy of her death. He knew about Timothy and that Jason had left his son behind, in the future. He knew about Daisy, too. To him, these memories were like watching a sad movie produced by an influential director. They brought tears to

his eyes, but they had less than 1% the impact on his psyche that they did to the real Jason.

Echo still possessed all the knowledge that Jason did, but when it came to Jason's life, Echo had none of the attachments to his family. Unlike Hope, Echo did not silently miss a life that had been stripped away from him.

He didn't think about its loss at all!

This was what made Echo a completely different entity from Jason and Hope. He was his own man.

Nadia flickered into reality inside the construct of her mind. She appeared at her husband's right side. He immediately smiled when he saw her.

"I told him." Nadia said.

"About time, babe." Echo said, turning to grab her and sweep her off her feet. he bent over and planted a passionate kiss on his wife's lips.

This was one of Echo's favorite moves. He loved literally sweeping Nadia off her feet. He couldn't keep his hands off her. He thought his wife was the most beautiful woman in existence, and this wasn't even something she had forced into his head. All Nadia had done was allow Echo to remember their 70 years together, locked in her MindCore. By doing that, he had immediately gained all the same feelings toward her that she had toward him. Some of those feelings were disjointed due to the fact that every single day of her imprisonment he had lost his memories of the day before.

But in Echo's mind, this was completely understandable. It was as if a man with a terrible memory condition had fallen in love with a woman thousands of times in his life, and then finally remembered all of them at once.

One of his hands pulled the back of her head towards his own. He forcefully kissed her over and over, while Nadia let out soft little moans that made him go feral with excitement. Naturally, he grabbed her ass with his other hand and squeezed, getting a kick out of the way her moans shifted pitch ever so slightly.

But this wasn't the time for a round of animalistic sex. They did that all the time, never tiring of it. This was just the way he always greeted his beloved. After a minute of passionate embracing, Echo let Nadia go. She flushed slightly and quickly regained her footing, using a hand to nudge her tousled hair back into place.

"I never get tired of that." Echo said with a grin. "So how'd he take it?"

Nadia took a moment to reorient herself. "He... he seemed okay with it. He thought your name was a bit silly though."

"Whatever. I like it. That's all that matters." Echo said.

"I like it too." Nadia agreed.

That was true. But then again, she liked anything Echo did.

Echo and Nadia chatted for a few minutes. Then another man approached from behind, a 30-year-old guy with dirty blonde hair and a full beard hanging a few inches off his chin.

"Hey, mom." The man said, smiling at Nadia as he leaned down and kissed her cheek. "How'd it go with Meatspace-man?"

"It went fine, Zachary." Nadia said. "He did suggest making a physical body for your father, though."

"Pft. I knew he would." Echo snorted, a hint of disdain in his voice. "That's probably what I'd have suggested when I was younger. And dumber."

Echo was currently standing beside the controls for the entirety of Nadia's MindCore. He had full administrative access, the same as her. He could create, monitor, and alter simulations at will. Unlike Jason, Echo did not have a MindCore of his own. He didn't have a GenesisFrame, and any attempts to simulate one fell flat.

But he didn't need one. Nadia's MindCore was essentially his. He had all the same capabilities. It was as if Jason himself had been given a RealitySim. Echo had hundreds of years of experience using it, too. He was even more proficient with it than Nadia.

Echo turned to the controls. He casually rested a hand on a metal pedestal with a glowing golden orb in its center. The world blurred around himself, his wife, and his son. They appeared inside a factory of some sort. Echo stepped away and walked toward an army of clones, each one looking exactly the same as him. Unlike Echo though, these clones were completely mindless. They had all the thoughts and memories he did, but he piloted them all remotely at the same time, similar to Jason's Dronesmiths. How he was able to do this at such a scale, even Nadia didn't know. She would struggle to do the same.

Echo casually walked over to one of his clone, who was delicately soldering circuits onto a very familiar-looking device. After a moment, Echo picked it up and examined it.

"Still no success at improving the PepScan." Echo concluded, turning to his wife after a moment. "I can improve the range of it dramatically, but then the potency falls off."

"That defeats the point." Nadia said, shaking her head. "Being able to copy people's existences into my RealitySim is the most important function of the PepScan."

"Yeah. I don't like that you need to get so close to someone to do so..." Echo said hesitantly. "It adds a heightened element of risk. But this is probably the best we'll get for the foreseeable future."

Echo was the one who had designed Nadia's PepScan. She had contributed in many important ways, but he was ultimately the core designer of it. He had plenty of time on his hands, unlike his wife, who was always in and out of her own MindCore.

Nadia hesitated for a moment. "You're sure you don't want to pay Realspace a visit?"

"Babe, no matter how many times you ask, the answer's still no." Echo said dismissively. "What's out there for me? Earth? I don't care about Earth. I don't care about a bunch of people Jason's attached to. My whole family's in here."

He continued. "The only reason I pay any attention to meatspace is because your real body exists in it. If something happened to you, I'd... well, it would be the worst day of my life. If you died, our entire family would die too. So I only care about the 'outside' in the sense of protecting and making you stronger."

Nadia smiled. She felt a sense of warmness from her husband's words that always improved her mood. No matter how down she was feeling, Echo's pure love would serve to invigorate her mind and soul.

"Yeah... I know." Nadia said quietly. "It's just that... sometimes... I wish you could hold me in the real world too."

"Maybe someday." Echo said, reaching over to caress her cheek. "Even if all of this is only in your head, doesn't it *feel* real?"

Nadia bobbed her head slowly. The passionate touch of her husband was just as real as if he existed in realspace. His touch, his kisses, his everything. They felt exactly the same as if he and Nadia were making skin-to-skin contact. She genuinely couldn't tell the difference.

"Yeah. Never mind then. You're right, I'm just being silly." Nadia said, smiling like a teenage girl hanging around her unrequited crush. She was just as excited to be around

Echo hundreds of years later as on the day they met. He was her everything.

Eventually, they got back down to business. Zachary started talking about his own work once his mom and dad put a temporary pause on their overwhelming romantic antics.

"Me and Tyler have been working on improvements to the H-Boy." Zachary said. "How has Jerome taken to it?"

"He's only just started a few minutes ago." Nadia said before correcting herself. "In real-time, I mean."

"So slow." Zachary grumbled. "How long until we get some results? I need hard data to improve the H-Boy."

"It'll probably be a few weeks." Nadia said, making the calculations in her head. "Jason insisted we let Jerome fumble around for the first hour or two."

Zachary was aghast. "Seriously? Why is that idiot always getting in the way? If you don't tell Jerome about the kinetic energy system, how will he know to-"

"Zach." Echo said coldly, directing a look toward his son that made him clamp up immediately. "We don't use words like that here. Just because Jason is behind me doesn't mean he's an 'idiot'. He has his own strengths."

Zach swallowed. He felt a little embarrassed by his dad's words. "Y-yeah. Sorry, dad. I'm just saying, you know? If mom had told Jerome..."

"Jerome's pretty smart." Echo said dismissively. "He'll figure it out. If he doesn't, that's fine. We'll bring him up to speed. Even if it's a couple hours in meatspace, it's only a few weeks of waiting for you. You'll be fine."

"I can't make any major changes to the internals until I get that data though!" Zachary complained.

"Then work on something else." Echo said. "What about that SIGIL system? Wasn't Tyler especially proud of that?"

Zachary felt his mood deflate. "Dad. We don't have hard data for *that* either."

"So make a simulation for it, then." Echo said.

"We don't know for sure if SIGIL's effects are the same in simspace versus realspace." Zachary argued. "That's why we need the data! Every bit of data improves the sims."

Echo grimaced. He scratched his chin thoughtfully. "Well. You're not wrong there. Just worry about it later, okay? Exercise a little patience. Work on something else in the meantime."

"...Alright." Zachary grumbled. "Well anyway. I'll leave you two lovebirds alone."

Zachary sauntered off, vanishing as he shifted himself into a different part of the RealitySim at will. Technically, he and all of Echo and Nadia's kids were administrators on the same level as Echo himself, but none of them were as proficient with the RealitySim as their father. They had been born inside and lived inside the sim their entire existences. They had no memory of realspace, and only knew about it from what they could simulate.

It was ironic that simulated people could only attempt to better simulate reality, but that irony was not lost on them. They only did so to improve the odds of protecting and improving their mother's life. As for actually traveling to realspace, none of them had any interest.

Once Echo and Nadia were alone, he cleared his throat. "Honey, no matter how badly you want it, I never will. Going back to meatspace just isn't for me. Leave all of that to Jason. My simmed existence gives me infinite pleasure."

"You really don't want to? Not even a little?" Nadia asked carefully.

"Not even the slightest bit. I have no attachments out there, except for you, and I get more of you in here thanks to time dilation than I ever would in meatspace." Echo explained. "Jason's doing important work. He has his goals, and I have mine. Let's leave it at that."

There was a long pause.

Echo stared ahead silently for a while.

"You know. I've been thinking a lot, lately. About time. Time travel." Echo said.

"Time travel? *You* have?" Nadia asked, slightly skeptical. "You've never mentioned it before."

"I was thinking about Hideki and how his time travel worked, versus Jason and Daisy's versions." Echo muttered. "Just random thoughts, is all. We know so little about it. We don't know for sure which form of time travel we exist in. Did Jason rewind time and

delete his future reality? Or is it still out there? Can he go back to it? Even if he can, will it be the same one? Or a different one that looks and feels identical?"

"Do *you* want to go to a different era?" Nadia asked.

"Babe. Come on. Of course not." Echo smirked. "I'm perfectly happy right where I am. I just feel bad for Jason, you know? It's like I'm looking at my younger brother who's had a hard life. I want to cheer him up, make him feel better. You know he's miserable, right? Like he's legit suicidal. I know I would be, if I were in his position. He's probably filled with self-hatred and doubt. It's a miracle he's held up this long."

Nadia was taken aback. She was a smart girl, and she had a copy of Jason inside her mind, but reading Jason's memories to get to know him wasn't the same as actually having 'been' him. Echo was missing a lot of parts of who Jason was now, but in essence, he and Jason came from the same starting blocks. He understood how he'd be feeling if, hypothetically, he were living the same life as Jason.

"Wife dead. Son left behind. Little girl tortured while he wasn't around to protect her. Dad's a fuckin' time traveling enigma. Of course Jason's a mess." Echo muttered out loud. "But he deserves respect. He's experienced a loss I've forgotten. It changed him, partly for the better, partly for the worse. I guarantee you Jason has more determination to improve than I do. He doesn't want to make the same mistakes he did in his youth... and I really respect that."

Nadia was quiet for a while. She lowered her eyes, thinking about what Echo had said.

She didn't have a retort. She also felt he was right. There was something really admirable about Jason's persistence. He had something Echo didn't.

"You have your own superior points." Nadia eventually said. "Jason's great, but so are you."

"Damn *right* I am. I'm fucking awesome." Echo said, giving his wife a thumbs-up. "And don't you ever forget it, babe. But also, don't let the kids blabber bad words about Jason either. They don't have the right."

"I won't. I'll put my foot down next time." Nadia vowed.

Nadia chatted with her husband for another hour or two. She eventually opened her eyes and returned to reality. Only a half-minute had passed. She immediately noticed Jason seemed quieter than before. He was staring off into the distance, lost in thought.

"Hey, Jason..." Nadia said softly. "You know I really admire you, right?"

Jason blinked. He seemed to leave his daze. "Huh? What did you say?" Jason asked.

"I said I really admire you." Nadia repeated.

"Oh. Uh. Thanks." Jason said. He looked at her like he was afraid she was going to jump at him, throw him to the floor, and start shoving her tongue in his mouth.

Naturally, such a silly thought hadn't even crossed her mind.

"I just think you're great. That's all." Nadia said, spinning up another forkful of noodles.

"Alright. Thanks, then..." Jason said warily. "Just remember that you're married, okay?"

Nadia smiled dreamily. "I'd never forget that."

Jason closed his eyes and massaged his forehead. *She's so weird sometimes,* he thought.